The Way You Used To Do

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Archive Warning:	Graphic Depictions Of Violence
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Fandom:	僕のヒーローアカデミア | Boku no Hero Academia | My Hero Academia
Relationships:	Bakugou Katsuki/Midoriya Izuku, Bakugou Katsuki & Midoriya Izuku, Ashido Mina & Bakugou Katsuki & Jirou Kyouka & Kaminari Denki & Kirishima Eijirou & Sero Hanta
Characters:	Midoriya Izuku, Bakugou Katsuki, Class 1-A (My Hero Academia), Yagi Toshinori | All Might, Aizawa Shouta | Eraserhead, Midoriya Inko, Bakugou Masaru, Bakugou Mitsuki
Additional Tags:	Soul Bond, Enemies to Friends to Lovers, Slow Burn, Mutual Pining, Pining, Hurt/Comfort, Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Angst, Angst with a Happy Ending, Fluff, Whump, Blood and Injury, Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder - PTSD, Recovery, Character Development, Developing Relationship, First Kiss, Therapy, Sign Language, Hard of Hearing Bakugou Katsuki, Deaf Bakugou Katsuki, Bakugou Katsuki Swears A Lot, Bakugou Katsuki is Bad at Feelings, Protective Bakugou Katsuki, Pining Bakugou Katsuki, Oblivious Bakugou Katsuki, Hurt Bakugou Katsuki, BAMF Bakugou Katsuki, Bakugou Katsuki Whump, Touch-Starved Bakugou Katsuki, Jealous Bakugou Katsuki, Jealous Midoriya Izuku, Oblivious Midoriya Izuku, Hurt Midoriya Izuku, Pining Midoriya Izuku, BAMF Midoriya Izuku, Protective Midoriya Izuku, Midoriya Izuku Whump, Dekusquad (My Hero Academia) - Freeform, Bakusquad (My Hero Academia) - Freeform, Sharing a Bed, Cuddling & Snuggling, Accidental Cuddling, Miscommunication, Near Death Experiences, Bakugou Katsuki Has One for All Quirk, Midoriya Izuku Has One for All Quirk, Bakugou Katsuki Has PTSD - Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder, Bakugou Katsuki Has Feelings, Worried Bakugou Katsuki, Ghost Midoriya Izuku, Character Turned Into a Ghost, Character Study, Bakugou Katsuki Redemption, Bakugou Katsuki Being an Asshole, Unresolved Emotional Tension
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Collections:	Love me some good secretive stuffs with a big reveal, BKDK Whump Club, Creative Chaos Discord Recs, BNHA Fanfic W(Rec)ks!, BKG AC, Katya's Korner Fic Recs, that good shit, Bakudeku fics, GBFOAT: Greatest BakuDeku Fics Of All Time 💥🥦, The Good (finished) BkDk, HighQualityBNHAFics, Behold the Sacred Texts, Bnha Bookclub Discord Recs, Deku Fics, The Collection From the Clouds, Cuteyyuki's Bakudeku, bnha fics !!!, ∞ BkDk/DkBk ∞, Storycatchers' pile of heroic hero stuff, StopTheSun Fav MHA Fics, kat's top-tier bnha fics, My

Personal Favorite Deku Fanfics, fics i wanna hold hands with, top tier MHA Fics, I'm Gonna Rec It, Boku No Hero Academia, These BNHA Fics Are Novel Quality, God Tier BNHA Fics, Amaris' Favorite Ever BNHA Fictions That She Has Read More Than You Can Count, Don't Forget These Fics, Ripon's Fanfic Recs, blasphemi's bnha fics, MHA works that make me happy this site exists, My Favorite Works, bnha angst, My Fave BakuDeku, Fics that cause me to be sleep deprived, 📚 Fanfic Forum Discord Recs, MHA fics that remind me why I'm alive 🌱 (previously "mha fics that keep me from working like a functional adult"), best of bkdk :'), Once Again Midoriya Izuku Is Catnip To Trouble, fics that altered my brain chemistry, Literally THE best of the bestEST fics in this Universe I'm not kidding, Fav BKDK Fics, soul healing comes from fanfiction, My Escapism List, 😛 A Reading List Made By A Total Ass (with good taste) mostly Mha probably... I know I have such a way with words 🙃, Faves and must-reads, the holy grail of fanfiction, shooks' fave bkdk fics, bakudeku love :) <3, WHAT KEEPS ME UP AT THREE AM, Fanfics que deveriam virar livros, Curated bakudeku, My BkDk Fics, Collection of treasures that I've cried river if it ever got delete :)), my fav bnha fics :D, Books I'd recommend - Queen of Kings YT, BakuDeku Things, My Hero Academia Favorite Fics, Fics I've Read That Are Longer Than Pride and Predjudice, Stellar Fics: A Wonder Duo Collection ☆★, Leo's Top Tier, Keep Coming Back 2, my hero academia: a medley, That good bkdk juice, MHA BKDK LOVE, Haru's Happy & Horny Horde, My Hero Academia, Adored Fics, Favourite_bitches_lol, Legitimately The Best Works I've Ever Read, my all time favorites!, Bnha books the gods approve of, Worth It BNHA Fanfics Reading List - Completed, Best of My Hero Academia, Read in reverence by rune, Rune Collections, The Best Fics I've Ever Read, Almost every Bakugou fanfic I have read, To Kill a Heart |completed bkdk|, From the Vault, Congrats You Made Me Actually Sob, Bnha masterpieces to read all the time🚱, retro-triscuit's favorite (bkdkbk) fics, BKDK fics that both broke and healed my soul 🧡💚, BkDk My Beloveds, 🌌 The Witch's Library, bkdk starter pack (the classics), Marmalade's MHA Mayhem ^_^, late night reads, fics for my BakuDeku addiction, Absolute masterpiece, Pie collection, mybkdk, SecretMagick's MHA Fics, Boom Bitch💥, Elite_Izuku_Centric_Fic_Recs, The Good Stuff n All That Jazz, lil' bkdk box of skittles (+others), Bakudeku Fics That Ripped My Heart Out And Made Me Question Existence, Partshally read mha fics, Sansthepacifist's favorite fics, Out of this World - literally, [simply the best], The Eternal Crack Server Fic Rec Collection, i spent my life chasing after you, i feel as though i have seen god, fav mha, Ones I would read again, Finished Fics, TOP synopsis (fics i wanna read), Wholesomeness en bandeja de plata, bkdk euphoria ;)., All Time Favorites, Favorite Bakugou Angst with a Dash of Fluff, fics i cant stop thinking about, exquisitas obras de literatura 🚬🚬, BKDK fics that are written better than BNHA 🥦💥, dark blue sagas, My absolute favourite fics, *chef's kisses*, Parsonsaj's Best of the Best of the Best, ♈ Tree's

	BakuDeku ♱, Keep Your Eyes On Me, class1akids bnha recs, Fics that give me some type of feeling, ghosts! but not ghosts 'aah!!' ghosts 'plot?', Need to Read, Plus Ultra, BKDK Brainrot (TiaLee), Tia's BNHA OGs and Good Reads, MHA Fics On My Comfort Shelf, bkdk fics that own my🫀, SakurAlpha's Fic Rec of Pure how did you create this you amazing bean, the pinnacle of bkdk fics 🙏💯, My drugies, DekuBaku that give me shivers, My Hero Academia, fluff fics, ❀ㄹ|아❀'s library, Anjum's sfw dkbkdk recs, greatest bkdk fics of all time, Ruth's assortment of treasures ✨, cute bakudeku❤️, My Absolute Favorites, Rebel Devil To Read, Best fucking read of my life, Maybe I Just Like Magic(Completed Favs), <3Fics that were recommended to me on TikTok(probably)<3, Being held hostage and forced to read (Bakudeku), My Favorite MHA Fanfics, literally BASED, Selected Best Reads, fics that are stuck in my head (rent-free)
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The Way You Used To Do

by edema_ruh

Summary

"We're really sorry," his father says, in a teary-eyed, wobbly way. "But your friend, Izuku, he's... He's gone, son."
Katsuki can do nothing but blink up at them for moments that feel like an eternity, eyes darting between both his parents in obvious confusion, disbelief, and, more than anything, indignation.
"What the fuck are you two talking about? The damn nerd is standing right beside you!"

During a battle, Midoriya gets hit by a villain whose quirk detaches his soul from his body. Stuck in a ghost-like state, the boy enters a race against time in order to save himself from permanently dying. Much to his luck - or lack of it -, the only person who can see and talk to him in this state is no one other than Kacchan.

Alternatively: Deku and Kacchan are soulbound.

Notes

You can also read this story in:
Russian.
Indonesian.

See the end of the work for more notes

- Translation into Português brasileiro available: The Way You Used To Do (PT-BR) by edema_ruh
- Translation into Italiano available: The Way You Used To Do (ITA) by Kukicha94
- Translation into Español available: La Forma En La Que Solías Hacerlo (TWYUTD en castellano) by Edema_ruh_works_in_spanish, Haconite, neszeth
- Translation into 中文-普通话 國語 available: 【授權翻譯｜幼馴染無差】昨日之日不可留 by mikiiiiiiiii

Chapter 1: The Beginning of the End

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

From the moment Midoriya felt the bone of his forearm snap as he fell full-weight on it, he knew he was doomed.

By now, he was used to having his bones break all the time – ever since he welcomed One for All into his body, feeling its power course through his veins as easily and as often as it snapped his limbs like twigs, he grew accustomed to the pain and the discomfort. However, habit didn't make the pain any easier to handle, and he didn't manage to hold back a startled yelp at the same time the "crack!" of his arm snapping filled the dark alley where he and Kacchan had been cornered.

"Stand up, idiot!", Katsuki shouted, standing in front of Izuku in a way that could have been interpreted as protective, had this not been Katsuki and Izuku, and sparing the fallen boy a quick glimpse over his shoulder before turning his focus back towards the threat ahead of them. "He's closing in", Bakugou warned, even though he didn't have to. Izuku might have had his vision blinded by a white flash of pain when his arm broke, but he could damn well see the man standing at the exit of the alley now, blocking their way out.

This had been supposed to be a simple patrolling activity, designed by UA to help training heroes to learn the protocols and nuances of patrolling. There weren't supposed to be any real villains at the area, just a couple of robbers or small criminals that students could handle with ease. However, Class 1-A seemed to have a special – and very much cursed – talent for making villains show up in places where there should be none. They should have all seen it coming, if Izuku was being honest with himself. A bit of pessimism wouldn't go amiss in these types of preparation.

He wished he could say it was fate who planned for him and Katsuki to be paired up and go on the first patrol round together, but it had been none other than Aizawa sensei. According to the teacher, this patrolling exercise was to be seen as a very profitable opportunity for both Midoriya and Bakugou to bond with each other, or "finally sort their shit out", as Kirishima put in a less elegant manner. Ever since their fatidic fight which resulted in house incarceration for both of them, Izuku and Katsuki hadn't actually spoken to each other more than they already did before, but they hadn't *not* spoken either. It was a complicated matter related to a complicated relationship that went a lifetime back and that certainly would not be simply solved by a talk with All Might and a simple week. Aizawa sensei seemed to be aware of that, Izuku was aware of that, Katsuki was *definitely* aware of that. But part of being a pro hero is being able to cooperate with your partners, even if they're not from the same agency, and if Izuku and Katsuki ever wanted to get anywhere near becoming number 1, they would have to learn how to deal and work with each other.

Yeah. Izuku definitely could see where Aizawa sensei was coming from when he paired him up with Kacchan. It didn't mean his arm hurt any less from being shoved to the floor by his alleged partner, though.

"Oi, shithead!", Katsuki called again when Izuku failed to respond. He had his arms stretched out beside his body in a position that was at the same time defensive and offensive. The man standing at the exit of the alley seemed unbothered by this display. "Who do you think you are to ignore what I'm fucking saying?"

"I'm not ignoring you", Izuku said through gritted teeth, taking a deep breath past the pain which was still pulsing like a hellish fire through his injured arm. Clutching the limb close to his chest and taking a series of deep breaths, he got back to his trembling feet and stood beside Katsuki, hating that he was being forced to hunch forward in order to bear the pain. To his left, Katsuki seemed unaware of the fact that he had just broken Izuku's arm by shoving him out of the way in an attempt to prevent them both from getting hit by one of the villain's energy beams.

"Sure, seems like it, *Deku*", Bakugou snarled, scoffing at Izuku's shaking form and spitting the nickname with venom in his tone. He sounded more pissed off than usual, but Izuku opted to ignore that. "Stop hugging yourself and tell me what that guy's quirk is", he ordered, his tone leaving no place for a discussion. Izuku turned his head towards him with an exasperated expression.

"How should I know?! I'm not a m-mind reader!", he protested nervously. "You're the one who dodged his attack, you tell me what his quirk is!", he added, sounding braver than he actually felt. Had this interaction taken place a year before, he would have cowered back beneath Katsuki's intense, death-bearing glare and quite possibly apologized for his harsh words. Now, all he did was glare back; defiance etched in his features even though he was trembling from head to toe with pain.

"What's the point of your stupid notebooks then, if you can't even tell what that asshole's quirk is?", Katsuki argued, and honestly, it was so half-hearted it ended up sounding like he spat the words only for the sake of arguing. "You know what, forget it. Leave it to me, you jerk", he huffed under his breath, clicking his tongue with disdain at Izuku and focusing his attention back on the villain, who hadn't moved from his spot at the exit of the alley.

"You think this is a test?", Izuku asked hesitantly, the words sounding uncertain to his own ears. "Maybe he was sent by Aizawa sensei –", he tried to argue, but Katsuki was quick to interrupt him.

"Only if Aizawa sensei finally got sick of your tiring nerd bullshit and decided to give you a quick, pointless ending at the back of a dirty alleyway", he scoffed, annoyed. "That guy there was aiming to kill. You used to know better than that, Deku", he added, which for some reason upset Izuku more than any of Katsuki's previous malicious comments.

"S-Sorry", he apologized, not because Bakugou was being mean but because he was right. He wasn't thinking straight, and the pain in his arm was probably the major contributor to that. Possibly noticing for the first time something wasn't quite right with Izuku, given the boy’s ludicrous and uncharacteristic suggestion, Katsuki finally turned his head in order to stare him for a bit longer, truly looking at him this time, instead of simply glancing. After a few seconds of assessment that felt way more intimate than they should, Katsuki finally spoke up.

"If you can't help, then don't", he said harshly, but Izuku could tell there was something in his eyes that strayed from annoyance or defiance. It almost sounded like Katsuki was trying to be responsible, rather than just put him down for once. "Stay back and let me handle this. I've got it", he said the words of reassurance in a dry tone.

"Kacchan –", Izuku tried to protest, but Katsuki pushed the boy back behind himself before he could continue, a bit too roughly.

"Shut the fuck up, shitty Deku", he scowled, going back to sounding like his usual self, as if the rare moment of level-headedness had been nothing but a slip. "Bad enough you got yourself injured before the fight even started", he accused, taking a step away from Izuku and towards the villain. As Izuku blinked in surprise at the words, Katsuki gained his distance, approaching the villain faster than the boy's pain-addled mind could comprehend.

"You're the one who broke my arm!", Izuku accused back, but Katsuki paid him no mind, halfway across the alley already. "Kacchan! Wait!", he shouted after his friend, following him close while still clutching the injured arm to his chest. Katsuki paid him no mind and continued forwards, where the villain remained impassive and unmoving.

"Move", Katsuki growled angrily at the villain blocking their way, standing mere feet away from the masked man. "Or *I'll* move you", he added with a dangerous smirk, igniting some explosions at the palm of his right hand as if to make a point. Midoriya caught up with Katsuki and stood beside him, staring at the villain with apprehension in his eyes.

"When I was told I would be facing training heroes tonight, I expected something…", the villain said in a scornful tone, eyeing Katsuki and Izuku from head to toe. "… grander", he concluded with something akin to disappointment in his voice. Izuku's heart froze and he didn't even have to look at Katsuki to know this wasn't going to end well.

"*Eeh*?!", Katsuki growled with indignation, already starting to fume. Izuku let go of his injured arm and closed his good hand into a fist at his side, already allowing One For All to flow through his body in anticipation. It was obvious that a confrontation was about to ensue.

"Kacchan", Izuku said with a warning in his voice, never removing his eyes from the villain.

"I'll show you something grand, you bastard!", Katsuki shouted right before sucker-punching the villain, explosions erupting from his hands and sending them both flying back. Izuku raised his good arm to protect his face from the blast, being shoved back by the sudden air dislocation caused by the explosion. Thankfully, he didn't fall back or lose balance, which enabled him to jump at the villain right before he managed to retaliate Katsuki's blow. Hitting the man's face with a well-given kick, which had been perfected thanks to his Shoot Style, Midoriya fell back to the floor at the same time Katsuki launched himself towards the villain, a loud cry of "DIE!" echoing through the alleyway as he struck the man with a series of explosions.

The villain was busy enough with Katsuki's powerful blows to focus on Izuku, who took the distraction to head towards the exit of the alley. He would never, in a million years, leave Kacchan behind or turn his back to a fight, but he needed to see if Aizawa sensei or anyone with a higher rank than them in UA were around. Much to his dismay, there was no one to be

seen on the street, which made him recur to the communication device he and Katsuki had been provided with right before they left for their round.

“Does anyone copy?!”, Izuku shouted frantically into his communicator, over the loud sound of Katsuki’s explosions and screams of “die!”. “Aizawa sensei! We are under attack! There's a villain here! Do you co– *Kacchan, watch out*!”, he cut himself off as he saw the villain was about to use one of his energy beams to hit Katsuki. Neither of them knew what the energy beam did – it looked like Aoyama’s navel laser, but it emerged from his hands and was tinged in a red hue. Izuku figured it was better for them not to find out.

His reflexes reacted faster than his mind and Izuku grabbed the lid of a nearby trash can, sending it flying towards Katsuki and managing to make the metal serve as a shield right before the villain’s energy beam hit the boy in the stomach. The villain seemed surprised by this, whereas Katsuki only looked offended.

“You think I didn’t see that coming?”, he shouted angrily at Izuku at the same time he aimed another well-pointed explosion towards the villain. “I told you not to get in the way, shitty nerd!”, he dodged one of the villain’s blows.

“We need to work together!”, Izuku pointed out, stepping back into the fight even though his broken arm was hanging limply beside him. “That’s the whole point of this exercise, isn’t it?”, he gave Katsuki an almost pleading look, to which the boy responded with an unreadable expression in his angry eyes.

“This ain’t an exercise, kiddo”, the villain said with a smirk, dodging Katsuki’s attack with grace and attempting to retaliate to it. The boy jumped back before the villain’s hands could grab him. “I have orders to kill”, he smirked, right before attempting to attack Katsuki again.

“Who sent you?”, Izuku asked at the same time he propelled himself forwards with One For All, hitting the villain on the stomach with a powerful kick and launching him towards Katsuki, who, predicting Izuku’s movements, made an elaborate maneuver across the air and finally knocked the villain down with a precise explosion. The man fell to the floor on his stomach, battered, and as he weakly attempted to get back to his feet, Katsuki simply placed a foot on his back, pushing him back towards the floor and pinning him there.

“Was that grand enough for you?”, Katsuki asked with scorn, scoffing. The villain writhed pathetically as he attempted and failed to move.

“Who sent you?”, Midoriya insisted, stepping closer to the fallen villain and panting slightly. He wouldn’t dare to say it out loud lest he increase Katsuki's anger, but he was quite proud that their synchronized attack had actually worked. All Might was right – if they worked together, they could become the best heroes in Japan. “Why are you attacking UA students in training?”

“You’re with the League, aren’t you?”, Katsuki asked, scowling with disdain and pressing his foot down harder on the man’s back. “You guys are all about boasting, not as much about accomplishing your goals. That Shigaraki sent you after me again?”, he raised an eyebrow.

“No”, the villain said, but much to Izuku’s confusion there was actually… humor in his voice? “But I’m sure he’ll thank me for finally getting rid of your annoying ass”, he added.

Everything happened at once.

Thanks to the enhanced perception One For All granted him, Izuku was able to read the villain’s intentions before they happened. Time slowed down around him as the man raised his hand and reached for Katsuki’s leg. Izuku could tell Katsuki had captured the movement as well, but the explosive boy's reaction to it was slow, too slow. The villain’s hand was glowing. He was about to grab Katsuki. There was no telling what he would do. Katsuki wouldn’t be able to dodge or stop him in time.

“Kacchan!”, Izuku screamed as he used his power to launch himself towards his friend, pushing him away from the villain before he managed to grab the boy’s leg. He enclosed his good arm around Katsuki’s waist as he used the momentum from his jump to push them both away from the villain’s grasp, flying midair. Before they hit the ground, something hot and painful hit Izuku’s back, burning him so intensely he couldn’t help but to cry out.

Katsuki collided with the brick wall behind them harshly, knocking his skull with such force he blacked out. Izuku should have controlled the intensity of his jump better, but in his rush to get Katsuki out of the way, he ended up overdoing himself. When Katsuki regained his senses, god knows how long later, Izuku was lying on the top of him, face buried in his chest and not moving.

Katsuki groaned in discomfort and took a hand to the back of his head, not surprised when it came back covered in fresh blood. There was a constant throbbing in his temples now, his vision blurry and swimming. He felt a bit nauseous, but swallowed past the lump in his throat as he tried to move. Izuku’s deadweight was pinning him down, but Katsuki didn’t need to move much to notice that the villain was gone, the alley empty of anyone other than himself and Midoriya. Who *still wasn’t moving*.

“Hey”, Katsuki called with annoyance, shaking one of Izuku’s shoulders in the hope that he would wake up and get the hell off him for once. “Wake up, shitty nerd. Nap time is over”.

No response. Izuku continued to lie very still, body splayed on the top of Katsuki’s, pinning him down. His arms were spread limply beside him.

“What the fuck are you doing, Deku?”, Katsuki asked, shaking him again. The annoyance in his voice was growing with each passing second. “Get the fuck off. I might still be able to catch him”, he tried to push the boy away and free himself. Izuku simply rolled limply to the side when Katsuki pushed him, limbs splayed in an unnatural manner on the floor and head lolling uselessly to the side once he was off Katsuki. It was only then that it dawned on him.

Deku’s eyes were open.

His face was slack, stuck in a ridiculous expression that was a mixture of pain and surprise, lips parted slightly and eyes half-lidded. Beneath the lids, Katsuki found a familiar green which lacked its even more familiar liveliness. No, Deku’s eyes were cold and empty, deprived of its usual spark and emotion. Deku’s eyes were dead.

“D-Deku…?”, Katsuki said, voice hoarse and barely above a whisper. He was aware that his eyes were very wide, and that his face had probably been overtaken by a horrified expression. His hands hovered above Izuku’s body, mere inches from touching it but never actually making contact, as if he was afraid of what would happen if he did. On the floor, Deku continued to stare at nothing with parted lips and dead eyes. “This is not the time for jokes, you idiot”, Katsuki said, suddenly angry. In fact, anger seemed to be his first response to everything. “Stop fooling around. You’re wasting my time”, he added, hoping that the reality of the situation would make Deku quit playing games already and get back on his feet. There was a chance they could still catch the villain and figure out what his quirk was. There was a chance…

Oh, god. Deku had gotten hit by the villain’s quirk, hadn’t he?

He had pushed Katsuki out of the way and got hit himself.

God *fucking damn* it.

“Deku, wake the fuck up”, Katsuki ordered, grabbing the front of Izuku’s ridiculous uniform and shaking the boy. The way Izuku’s head simply lolled lifelessly in accord to Katsuki’s jolting movements was sickening, to say the least. “I’m serious, you asshole. Get up. Wake up. Come on”, he slapped a hand at the unmoving boy’s cheek, in the hope that it would urge some life into him or at least snap him out of his shock. Deku always responded to his aggressions, even if it was to needlessly apologize.

“Wake up”, Katsuki ordered, getting angrier by the second. His hands tightened into fists and he wished to beat the bloody life out of Deku, because he couldn’t be dead. There was no way in hell Deku was dead. Not like that. Not after all the trouble he went through to achieve and nurture his quirk. Not like *that*. “You goddamn piece of shit, wake the hell up!”, he found himself shouting at Deku’s face, never ceasing to shake him. He grabbed Deku’s shoulders and squeezed tight, aiming to hurt, aiming to make him react in some way. Any way. He jolted the boy again, making his limp head rattle. “Is this what you’re gonna do, huh?!”, Katsuki yelled angrily at the boy in his grasp. “Is this how you’re gonna go? You gonna let yourself be taken down by some D-lister? Is this the heir to All Might’s power?”, he accused angrily, not caring that someone could be hearing.

There was no one around. They were alone.

He was alone.

Deku was dead.

“Is this what you fucking wanted?”, Katsuki abruptly let go of Izuku’s body, making it fall back and collide heavily with the floor. His eyes were still open. His fucking *green eyes*. “Are you happy now? I bet you’re fucking having a laugh right now, huh?”, he sniffed. There were tears pooling in his eyes, but Katsuki knew better than to let them flow. There was no reason to. He didn’t even like stupid Deku in the first place, right? There was no point in crying for him. The nerd got what was coming for him, what Katsuki always warned him about.

God. He was dead. Because of him.

He felt nauseous. He felt sick. he probably had a concussion, which he convinced himself to be the reason behind his growing tears. Because there was no way he was crying because of Deku. Not Deku. Anyone but Deku. He wasn't *crying*.

"You goddamn idiot", Katsuki shook his head, voice breaking. Furious at the irrational display of weakness, he grabbed Deku by the shoulders again, having to control himself not to let explosions erupt from his hands in his emotive state. "You *goddamn idiot*! Why did you have to do that for, huh? Why did you have to play the martyr like you always do, fucking Deku? You fucking piece of shit, I hate you!", he screamed at Izuku's pale, slack face. "I *hate you*! You fucking moron, I hate you! I told you to stay the fuck back, I told you I had it! Why did you have to go and do that for, huh? I don't fucking need you to save me! Stupid piece of shit!", he shoved Izuku away from him, not bothering to look at the probably gruesome result of his harsh shove. Katsuki didn't think he would be able to bear seeing Deku's body splayed all twisted and askew on the floor like he was a doll. Like he was a… a deku.

Instead, he buried his face between his knees and shoved both hands at his hair, tugging and pulling at the strands at full strength at the same time he ignored the blood coating his fingers. He had hit his head. He had a concussion. There was a chance, albeit small, that he was just hallucinating this whole thing, that Deku was playing a sick prank on him, that this whole situation was just a bad dream resulting from that sicko's quirk. He tried to regain his composure and squeezed his eyes shut for several moments, calming himself down. When he opened his eyes, it would all be gone, right? He just needed to think. He just needed… he just needed…

He opened his eyes, slowly turning his head to the side. Deku was lying still on the floor in the same position Katsuki had shoved him, on his side, arms stretched in front of him, legs twisted.

Lips parted.

Eyes open.

Face pale.

Katsuki stared at Izuku's dead body, who seemed to be staring right back at him.

Katsuki stared.

Katsuki stared.

Katsuki gagged.

He turned as far away from Izuku and spilled the contents of his stomach on the floor, feeling dizzy and sick. He couldn't tell if his nausea had been caused by his concussion or by the sight of a dead Izuku in front of him. *Because* of him. As much as he had always hated the nerd, he had never really wanted him to die. Not because of him, at least.

He crawled his way back to Deku's side, sitting cross legged beside him and staring. His surroundings began to lose color and he was pretty sure he could feel the blood tricking down

his neck and his back, from the injury on his head. That probably explained why he felt so dizzy, so lightheaded. So groundless. So lost.

He passed out at some point, never leaving Izuku's side. He vaguely remembered the sound of a girl screaming and of orders being shouted, but by the time Uraraka, Iida, Todoroki, and Aizawa sensei arrived at the scene, Katsuki was too far gone to pay them any mind.

"Bakugou", the Half'n'Half bastard appeared in front of him, crouched so that he was directly in Katsuki's field of vision. He was still sitting cross-legged beside Deku, since the little shit was refusing to wake up. Katsuki, in his concussion-addled head, figured he would just have to sit beside the stupid nerd until he decided naptime was over. "Bakugou, are you with me?", Todoroki frowned, actually looking concerned.

"Deku-kun! Deku-kun!", Round Face was screaming and sobbing from somewhere. Katsuki didn't really mind her.

"He's unresponsive", Todoroki told someone behind Katsuki, not looking at him. "He must have a pretty bad concussion, if the amount of blood is anything to go by".

Suddenly, Aizawa sensei appeared beside Todoroki, the impassive look on his face replaced by something more somber that Katsuki couldn't quite name. He assessed his student for a few silent moments before finally addressing him.

"What happened?", he asked simply. Briefly. Katsuki simply stared at him.

"We need to take him back, sensei!", Uraraka sobbed loudly. "Recovery Girl is back there; she can fix him! We need to move Deku-kun!"

"Sensei, I agree", Iida said, even though the grief on his face was evident. "There may still be… a chance, however small, that Recovery Girl…"

"Don't talk like that, Iida-kun!", Uraraka protested desperately. "She can fix Deku-kun! I know she can!"

"Stop it…", Katsuki muttered, so low and so hoarsely that no one seemed to hear him.

"No one touches Midoriya until she arrives. I have already contacted her", Aizawa sensei instructed, gesturing at the way Izuku's body was lying all twisted and askew on the floor. "His spine could be broken and we wouldn't want to aggravate it by moving him in the wrong way. Some things, not even Recovery Girl can fix".

Right. All those people were bigger idiots than Katsuki first thought.

"But sensei, the longer we take to move Deku-kun…!", Uraraka tried to protest.

"Stop", Katsuki said, firmer this time. Half'n'Half seemed to hear him this time, but simply spared him an enigmatic look before turning to Uraraka. He seemed to be avoiding looking at Izuku's twisted body ever since he arrived, now that Katsuki thought about it.

“She’s right, I could try to slide him over there using my ice”, Half’n’Half suggested. “The longer we stay here waiting, less are the chances he’ll –“

“Not you too, Todoroki-kun!”, Uraraka cut him short before he could resume that thought. “We need to believe in Deku-kun! If anyone can get out of impossible situations, it’s him! I know he’ll make it! ‘Deku’ means he can do it!”

“Fucking *stop* it already, Round Face!”, Katsuki exploded, startling everyone around him. Uraraka turned to face him with wide, shocked eyes, as if she was noticing his presence there for the first time.

“Bakugou”, Aizawa sensei said, a warning in his tone. He reached out a hand to touch Katsuki’s shoulder, but the boy flinched away from the contact.

“Don’t”, he shook his head, ignoring how dizzy the movement made him.

“Bakugou-kun, I…”, Uraraka said, tear tracks evident on her red cheeks. She stared at Katsuki with the utmost confusion. “I don’t…”

“Stop it. Don’t call him that”, Katsuki said simply, offering no further explanation. “Just fucking *don’t*”, he scoffed bitterly, lowering his head. He swallowed dry, the disgusting taste of bile lingering on his tongue. He was getting dizzier and dizzier with each breath he took, reality feeling detached.

“B-But… I thought…”, Uraraka trailed off, unsure of what to say. Katsuki’s eyes were starting to droop and, from the look of him, it didn’t seem like he would be able to stay awake for much longer, if the gruesome state of his head was anything to go by.

“He didn’t break his spine” Katsuki announced simply, not meeting anyone’s eyes. He didn’t think he could if he wanted to. “You can move him. Not that it’ll be of much use, anyway”, he scoffed.

“Bakugou”, Aizawa sensei called again, sounding more serious now that his student had finally broke out of whatever trance had been preventing him from speaking moments before. “What happened?”

Katsuki’s head snapped up painfully at his teacher’s tone, anger, frustration and grief evident in his hazy crimson eyes. His face was paler than usual, but there was still an undying fierceness in him that didn’t seem to be leaving him anytime soon.

“He called you and you didn’t come”, he accused childishly. “That’s what happened”.

Everyone stared at him. The blood running down his neck and the way his eyes didn’t seem to be able to focus on anything only made the scene worse.

“He’s a fucking moron with no self-preservation whatsoever”, he added bitterly. “*That’s* what happened”.

Todoroki turned his head to the side and sighed, and Katsuki couldn’t tell if that was because he agreed with what he was saying or because he simply didn’t want to have to deal with

Katsuki when he was like that. Aizawa sensei kept his eyes fixed on the explosive boy.

“I was here”, he added finally, a lump appearing in his throat. “And the guy was going for me. That’s what happened”.

Nobody said a word.

“If…”, Iida, the brave soul, was the one to finally break the almost tangible silence in the air, nervous. “If Bakugou is right and his spine isn’t broken, we should… We should move him”, he suggested finally.

Aizawa, eyes fixed on Bakugou, simply nodded.

“Ochako. Use your quirk to make Midoriya float. Todoroki, you guide him to the medical area”, he instructed simply, not looking at any of them as he spoke. His eyes were fixed on Katsuki and Katsuki alone. Katsuki, on the other hand, had his attention fixed on Izuku, and on the way his limp body began to float and the Half’n’Half bastard urged him towards the street, head turned away so that he wouldn’t have to face the unmoving boy and an alien look on his face making his brow twist. Something angry and irrational boiled inside Katsuki and, before he knew better, he was on his feet, swaying dizzily and pathetically as he tried to adapt to the blood loss and failed.

“Oi, Half’n’Half”, he called after Todoroki, who spared him an unreadable look. Katsuki was hardly able to stay on his feet and he knew he was about to collapse any minute now, but he still pointed an accusing finger at Todoroki and gave him the nastier glare he could muster. “If you hurt Deku, I’ll kill you”.

Katsuki was too out of it to notice the confused, pitying looks Uraraka and Iida sent him. None of them had the heart to correct him or judge him for his words, since he was clearly affected by blood loss and… by whatever it was he had witnessed in that alley. Todoroki simply nodded his head in acknowledgement to Katsuki’s words before resuming his task of taking Izuku to the Medical Area.

And then Katsuki collapsed.

Aizawa sensei managed to grab him before he could hit the floor, passing one of Katsuki’s arms around his shoulder and sustaining his weight into an upright position. Katsuki wanted to protest, but found he lacked the strength to. Everything around him was gray and swimming, and his tired eyes could no longer focus on anything. He felt a twist of embarrassment as his bloodied head lolled onto Aizawa sensei’s shoulder, but his limbs felt like lead and his tongue felt like cotton. He wouldn’t be able to deny his sensei's help, even if he could speak. Black and white spots danced in front of his vision, and he vaguely wondered how much blood he had lost.

And then.

“Oh my god, Kacchan! Are you ok? Kacchan, what happened to you?!”

There was only one person in the world who called him that.

Katsuki's droopy eyes widened slightly in shock and he used the last of his strength to turn his head around towards the source of that familiar voice, but just as his eyes connected with freckled cheeks and green, worried, lively eyes, his consciousness finally escaped him and he collapsed onto Aizawa sensei's arms as his knees gave out.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading this! This is my first work for the BNHA fandom, so I hope it turns out ok!
Twitter: Twitter
Tumblr: Tumblr
Bluesky: Bluesky

Chapter 2: Bakugou's Not-really-imaginary Not-really-friend

Chapter Summary

> Katsuki turned his head so that he could whisper something in Izuku's ear and, despite knowing that this Izuku was nothing other than a ghost, a projection, an intangible spirit, Katsuki could have sworn he could feel the tickle of Izuku's curly hair brushing against his cheek, at the same time Izuku could have sworn he felt the warmness of Katsuki's breath making his neck tingle.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

When Katsuki woke up, he didn't remember what had happened to him.

There was some sort of bandage enveloping his head and a constant, dull throbbing making it hard for him to focus on his surroundings, and when he finally dared to blink his eyes open, the bright light sent a stab of pain across his skull. He hissed loudly, squeezing his lids shut and grinding his teeth. God, he hated concussions.

He didn't remember how he had gotten himself concussed, though, which was why he attempted to open his eyes again. Knowing what to expect this time, the pain wasn't so unbearable. He blinked his crimson eyes several times until they finally regained focus, and found himself staring up at the unmistakable ceiling of Recovery Girl's medical center.

"Kacchan?", a hesitant voice called from somewhere beside him. Katsuki felt annoyance blossom in his chest but turned his head towards the nerd, already putting on a scowl. Deku's face lit up in relief once Katsuki's eyes focused on him, sighing and allowing his shoulders to drop. "Oh, you're awake again", he breathed out, a shy smile appearing on his lips. He looked pale.

"What do you mean 'again'?", Katsuki growled, voice hoarse and throat aching. He shifted on the bed with difficulty, pushing himself into a more seating position. Izuku looked like he wanted to help him, but changed his mind before he could. "Fuck, my throat is sore. Is there any water around, nerd?", he glared at Deku, who looked away with an embarrassed expression.

"How are you feeling?", Izuku asked instead of answering Katsuki's question. He didn't meet his eyes as he spoke.

"Shitty and thirsty", Katsuki spat out simply, already feeling grumpy and annoyed. The throbbing headache he was being forced to deal with wasn't exactly helping with his already sour mood. "You gonna grab me that water or what?", he asked in an angry tone, because he was physically incapable of saying things like 'please' and 'thank you' to Deku, of all

people. However, his venomous request only made Izuku blush and turn his head further away, some color finding its way to his deathly pale face. Katsuki didn't like that. The whiter Deku's face looked, the more his ridiculous freckles stood out.

"Kacchan, I –", Izuku found the courage to start, but was interrupted by the door of the room opening. Katsuki had been expecting to see Recovery Girl coming in, but the sight of his parents making their way to his bed placed a frown on his face and sent a twist to his heart. They wouldn't have come unless something serious had happened.

"Katsuki", his mother greeted, running a hand through his hair and staring down at him with a grim face. His father took the empty seat beside the bed and grabbed one of his hands, giving him an almost apologetic look. Katsuki frowned in confusion.

"What are you two doing here?", he asked, sounding a bit more aggressive than he had intended. His mother looked like she wanted to slap him for his insolence, whereas his father simply squeezed his hand.

"How are you feeling, son?", he asked, offering Katsuki a smile so fake that something dreadful gnawed at the explosive boy's insides. What the hell was going on?

"Shitty and thirsty", he repeated the same thing he had told Deku, sparing the boy a pointed glare that read 'see? Maybe they'll do something about it, unlike you, shitty nerd'. Deku continued to eye him with a pale face and attentive eyes from where he was standing right beside Katsuki's mom, unusually silent.

"I'll grab you some water", his mom announced simply, turning on her heels and disappearing from Katsuki's vision. His father sighed audibly and lowered his head, looking conflicted. The sight made a renewed sense of anger and impatience sparkle inside him.

"Ok, what the hell is going on?", he asked when his father gave no indication he was about to speak up. "And seriously, don't sugarcoat me. You know I can handle it, whatever this is", he added matter-of-factly. He looked at where Deku was still standing behind his father, searching the nerd's face for any indication of what was wrong, but the boy continued to look at him in silence, face full of sharp attention. His father stared up at him with that annoyingly apologetic expression again.

"What do you remember from yesterday, son?", his father asked, cautious. Katsuki sighed and rolled his eyes, but he put a special effort on remembering what he could.

"I went out patrolling with shitty Deku", he said after a few seconds of concentration, pointing Deku with a glare. "We found a villain or something. I'm guessing I must have hit my head fighting him, because that's all I can remember. It was probably Deku's fault", he snarled at the boy. His father frowned and looked over his shoulder at where Katsuki was staring, a concerned look on his face. He was probably worried Katsuki had hurt Deku's feelings or some crap. Deku, on the other hand, looked unbothered by the accusation.

"Katsuki, we…", his father started at the same time his mother entered the room again, a cup of room-temperature water in hands. She handed it over to her son without a word, staring at him as he took a sip. Katsuki twisted his nose.

“It's warm", he complained, staring down at the cup as if it had personally offended him. The water did soothe his raspy throat, but he would rather have it cold.

“It's room-temperature", his mom corrected with impatience, crossing her arms above her chest. “Now shut up and drink it. You said you were thirsty. Cold water will only damage your throat further”.

“Fine, whatever”, he mumbled with annoyance, downing the rest of the water. His father sighed and used the interruption to recompose himself. Once Katsuki was done with the water, he handed the glass back to his mother, who took it silently. “So?”, he urged when neither of his parents gave any indication of telling him what had happened. “Are you gonna spit it out or what?”

His father spared his mother a knowing glance and turned back to him with another sigh, never letting go of his hand.

“Son, we… We're really sorry", his father said, in that teary-eyed, wobbly way Katsuki most certainly didn't inherit from him, thank fuck. "But your friend, Izuku, he's...", he hesitated for a moment, as if trying to find the right words for that situation. Katsuki frowned. "He's gone, son", he concluded, giving Katsuki's hand a squeeze. Behind him, his mother stood, face almost as impassive as ever.

Katsuki could do nothing but blink up at them for moments that feel like an eternity, eyes darting between both his parents in obvious confusion, disbelief, and, more than anything, indignation. He had never been a big fan of being made fun of.

"What the fuck are you two talking about?", he asked, sounding angry but not as aggressive as he would have liked to. "The damn nerd is standing right beside you!", he pointed at where Deku was standing beside his mother, looking even more pale, if that was even possible.

His parents exchanged a worried look, which sent a renewed wave of fury across Katsuki. What, they thought they knew better than him? They thought he was crazy? Why the fuck did they have that pitying look on their faces?

“They can’t see me, Kacchan”, Deku said simply, almost apologetically. “So far, I think you’re the only one who can".

“We understand this is difficult for you", his father continued, overlapping Deku's apology without paying any mind to the boy. Katsuki's frown deepened. “We also know your relationship with Izuku hasn’t been on the best of terms, but… He’s gone, son. He was brain dead when he arrived here. The only reason why they didn’t shut off the life support is…”

“Inko and All Might didn’t allow it", his mom concluded when his father trailed off. She looked sad, but her expression was angrier than anything. “They refuse to give up hope, but to all effects, the kid is gone”, she stated simply. Truthfully.

“Ok, whatever this is, you gotta cut this shit right now”, Katsuki scoffed impatiently, pointing at Deku again. “If Deku is dead, how is he standing right there? I’m not a fucking basket

case, I know what I'm seeing", he added, ignoring the jolt of fear that coursed through his heart at the possibility that he was actually starting to lose it and that Deku was actually dead.

"Son, like I said, we know this is hard", his father said again, ever the compassionate, comprehensive man. "You hit your head pretty badly, you witnessed the whole thing first hand. We understand. You can take all the time you want to recover. Aizawa sensei told us that you won't be punished for not attending classes until you're better. But the worst course of action you could take right now is denial", he said condescendingly. Katsuki fumed at this.

"It's not denial, he's right *there* –", he shouted angrily, but his mother interrupted him before he could have a full-on angry breakdown that was very usual to the Bakugou family.

"Look, kid, we get it. You treated Midoriya like shit and now he died to save your ass. It's an awful situation, you must be feeling like crap and all that. But pretending it didn't happen won't help anyone, especially not you", she said with honesty, in that crude way that was so natural to her. "The fastest you accept what happened, the fastest you can move on".

"What the *fuck* do you mean he died to save me, old hag?!", Katsuki asked, indignity evident in his tone. "I don't need to be saved by that piece of shit!", he pointed an accusing finger at Izuku, who took a careful step closer to the bed. "Deku! Fucking talk to them already! Why can't they fucking see you?"

"I don't k-know", Izuku said in that wobbly way Katsuki loathed so much. His lower lip was quivering nervously. Behind Izuku's approaching form, Katsuki's parents exchanged another look, as if trying to decide whether their son had lost his mind or not. "But, Kacchan, you need to calm down or you'll make your concussion worse –"

"Don't tell me what to do, nerd!", Katsuki protested angrily, shoving the blankets off his legs and throwing them off the bed, ready to stand up, march his way down to Deku, and see for himself whether he was actually dead or not.

"Katsuki, you need to stay in bed!", his father shouted in alarm, trying – and failing – to hold his son back. Katsuki got to his trembling feet and swayed for a second before regaining his composure and resuming his march out of the room.

"Kacchan!", Deku called after him in that exasperated tone of voice that got to Katsuki's nerves every time. "You're going to hurt yourself! Can you just listen to me for once?!"

"Shut the fuck up, Deku!", Katsuki said over his shoulder, never ceasing his march.

"Katsuki, get back here right now!", his father tried to grab him, but his mother stopped him with a warning hand.

"No, don't. Let him see it for himself", she advised, eyeing her son with a stern look. "Maybe it'll help him wake up and face reality at once".

"Where is he?", Katsuki demanded with a growl, to which his mother rolled her eyes.

“Third room to your left”, she provided simply, earning a distraught look from her husband. “And brat", she added before Katsuki could resume his march. He looked at her over his shoulder, ignoring the way the movement made his head sting. “We all know you’re strong, but don’t let this take you down”.

Katsuki didn’t bother to reply as he continued his march to Deku's room and shoved the doors open without knocking.

The first thing he saw was the hunched, sobbing figure of Izuku's mother beside the bed, and the way her head snapped up abruptly at Katsuki's sudden intrusion. Behind her, All Might stood in his puny form, the grieving look on his face making his sulky cheeks look even more sunken.

Then, on the bed, lied Izuku. Covered in all sorts of wires. A tube shoved in his mouth. His scarred hand covered in bruises. His left arm enveloped in a cast.

Face pale.

Hair disheveled.

Unmoving.

A spark of memory appeared in Katsuki’s head, of half-lidded green eyes and parted lips and death. He shuddered.

“Young Bakugou", All Might said sternly. “Shouldn’t you be in bed?”

Instead of responding, Katsuki took a tentative step towards the bed, horror etched on his face. Turning his head to the side, he found Deku standing right beside him, a similar look on his own face. How could it be that Deku was lying unmoving on the bed and standing beside Katsuki at the same time? Maybe he was, in fact, losing his mind.

“I hadn’t seen it yet", Izuku whispered quietly beside him, eyes wide and teary. He looked worried.

“What?”, Katsuki asked, frowning. Why hadn’t Deku tried to see his own body before this?

“I said: ‘shouldn’t you be in bed’?”, All Might repeated, assuming Katsuki’s question had been directed to him. “You’re not looking well, young man. You should rest and regain your energy to recover”.

“No, not you", Katsuki waved a very impolite, dismissive hand at the man, eyes focused on Deku standing beside him. “Why didn’t you come here before?”

“I tried”, Izuku admitted, stepping closer to the bed and looking like he wanted to grab his own hand, but was afraid to do so. “But every time I tried to leave your side, I got pulled back. Like a magnet”, he whispered, awe etched on his face.

“That doesn’t make any fucking sense", Katsuki scoffed. “Why me? Why can’t anyone else see you?”

“I don’t know", Izuku admitted quietly. “Maybe it was because you were the only other person there when I was hit?”, he suggested half-heartedly.

“Young Bakugou", All Might called, concern evident in his features. Inko was also staring at Katsuki as if he had grown a second head. “Who are you talking to?”, he asked, cautious. Katsuki huffed through his nose.

“To fucking Deku”, he explained, trying his best to sound certain, instead of delusional. “He’s standing right beside me".

“W-What?!”, Inko startled, green eyes widening and lips quivering in a very Midoriya-like way. All Might placed a hand on her shoulder to ground her. “You can see him? Where? Where is my baby?”

“Mom", Izuku stepped in front of his mother, tears already pooling on his big, expressive eyes. He crouched in front of her, placing each hand on her knees affectionately. “Mom, I’m right here", he said pleadingly, as if begging her to see him.

“He’s crouching in front of you", Katsuki informed coldly, watching the scene in front of him with impassive eyes. The sight of Deku's dead body on the bed was still unsettling, even if he was still breathing with the aid of the life support.

Inko blindly reached for her invisible son, her hand running right through him. Izuku was as intangible as Mirio and as invisible as Hagakure. The only one who could see him was Katsuki.

“Your hand just ran through him", Katsuki announced in a flat tone, making Inko withdraw her hand from where it was stretched as if it had been burned, a horrified look on her face.

“Izuku! Did I hurt you?!”, she asked frantically, eyes darting across the empty space in front of her in a desperate, fruitless attempt to find her son. Izuku lowered his head and shook it, shoulders slumping in disappointment.

“No. I didn’t feel anything”, he admitted, not bothering to look at Katsuki. He sounded miserable.

“He’s fine", Katsuki relied the information to the desperate mother, but sighed and rolled his eyes in annoyance. “Look, I’m done playing carrier pigeon for you lot. Can anyone tell me what the fuck is going on?!”, he asked with exasperation. Izuku stood up from his mother's feet and went back to looking at his body, a pensive look on his face. All Might looked conflicted, at the same time Inko continued to look around the room helplessly, as if hoping Izuku would appear magically any moment now.

“Young Bakugou…”, All Might finally said, voice heavy and constricted. “Are you sure…”, he hesitated for a moment. “Are you sure you are seeing young Midoriya?”

“Uh, yeah?”, Katsuki said as if he was talking to a child who asked too many questions. An offended look passed his face. “What, you think I’m a nutcase too?”, he scoffed angrily, recalling his parents' reaction mere minutes before. “I don’t know how or why, but I’m

apparently the only one who can see and listen to the damn nerd, which is just my fucking luck, right? Of all the people in the world who could be haunted by Deku's shitty ghost, it had to be me?", he scowled bitterly, clicking his tongue. "Tch. I have no reason to make this up, why the hell would I want people to believe I'm the only one who can talk to *Deku*? That's just – are you *fucking* kidding me right now?!", Katsuki asked with exasperation as he saw what Izuku was trying to do. The boy was trying to lie down on the bed, clearly thinking that if his soul lied on the top of his own body, he would be able to reconnect with it somehow.

"What? What is going on?", Inko asked, green eyes widening again, and Katsuki low-key wished she would stop doing that, because the look was familiar in an uncanny way that made him shiver.

"Young Bakugou?", All Might urged, equally curious. Katsuki paid them no mind, approaching the bed with an angry look on his face.

"You really think you can reenter your body like that, you moron?", he scoffed. "What, you just gotta lie down there and wait until your shitty soul is pulled back into your stupid-ass tiny body? Un-fucking-believable, Deku", he shook his head in disapproval.

"My body isn't tiny!", Izuku protested, sitting up on the bed and making the sight before Katsuki's eyes something uncanny to witness. At the same one Deku lied down covered in wires on the bed, another paler, slightly more transparent Deku sat down, making it look like his soul was actually leaving his body. Katsuki twisted his nose, not really comprehending why the sight made his heart speed up.

"Get the fuck out of there, having to see one of you is already enough", he gestured frantically at the boy. "Shit, never in my life I thought I'd be forced to deal with two Dekus. I'm pretty sure this is a nightmare designed to especially torment me", he huffed. Izuku rolled his eyes but hopped off the bed anyway, looking upset.

"Whatever, it didn't work anyway", he muttered sadly. "But I figured it was worth a try".

"Young Bakugou, I have to ask you not to speak in that way in front of Mrs. Midoriya", All Might scolded at the same time as Izuku spoke, making it difficult for Katsuki to pay attention to the both of them at the same time. "Please, show some respect for a mother in this moment of difficulty".

"Of course it didn't fucking work, if it was that easy your crappy ghost wouldn't be standing around and making people think I've lost my damn mind!", Katsuki decided to answer Deku, because if there was one thing in which he excelled at was teasing the boy. At least that was the only familiar territory he seemed to be able to trade at that time. He was being forced to deal with ghosts, near-death experiences, and the slight possibility that he was actually descending into insanity, but in the middle of all this mess, teasing Deku and calling him names was the only familiar ground where he could step on.

"Well, I'm sorry, Kacchan, but I'm not loving this situation, either!", Izuku protested, looking exasperated. He scratched the back of his head nervously and looked at where his mother was

still sitting, face more distraught than before. “Mom", he tried calling her attention again, to no avail. “Mom! Please, hear me!”, he begged, growing frantic. Katsuki scowled again.

“She can’t hear you, dipshit", he reminded Izuku with a frown.

“Mom!”, Izuku tried again, shoulders slumping when his mother continued unaware of his presence.

“Young Bakugou", All Might called him again, unaware of how frantic and loud Izuku was growing. The boy's high-pitched voice was not only aggravating Katsuki's headache, but it was also getting to his nerves. “No one is questioning your sanity, but we should be careful not to give Mrs. Midoriya false hope –“

“No!”, Inko protested, cutting the symbol of peace off mid-speech. “I believe Katsuki. I have to believe him", she added in a wobbly voice, lowering her head.

“I know”, All Might nodded solemnly. “And I want to believe him too, but Mrs. Midoriya…”, he sighed heavily, full of grief. “Young Bakugou went through a traumatic experience –“

“I’m not traumatized!”, Katsuki immediately protested. He didn’t even remember what had happened; how could he be traumatized?

“ – and this could all be nothing more than an unhealthy way his mind found to cope with what he was forced to witness", All Might concluded, unbothered by his student's interruption.

“Ehh?”, Katsuki growled, indignant. Even All Might, symbol of peace, hope personified, refused to believe him? Was there a chance he was actually crazy?

“We need to convince them we're saying the truth, Kacchan!”, Izuku cried desperately. “They can’t keep believing I’m dead!”

“They can’t keep believing I’m *crazy*", he snapped his head towards Izuku's distraught face, twisting his nose. Izuku looked at him with wide eyes that were identical to his mother’s, but nodded after a beat.

“Look", Katsuki took a deep breath to calm himself – not that it was of much use –, pinching the bridge of his nose and closing his eyes for a moment before addressing All Might again. “Yeah, I get where everyone is coming from. I wouldn’t believe it either if some bastard woke up after bashing their head, saying they were seeing the ghost of someone who is brain dead. But, one, I don’t really remember what happened to Deku, so me seeing the shitty nerd can’t be a coping mechanism; two, I don’t even like Deku, so there’s no reason I'd be traumatized if he died”, he ignored the way Izuku flinched beside him, “and three, I don’t think I’m crazy either, because this idiot literally tried to reenter his body by lying down on the top of it, and there’s no way my subconscious would ever come up with something so stupid, so he can’t be a hallucination", he pointed out sternly. All Might seemed to be trying to figure out whether Katsuki’s points made sense or not, and the hope in Mrs. Midoriya’s

eyes simply increased. Izuku fidgeted with the hem of his shirt as he nervously waited for a response.

“We need to tell him something only I would know”, Izuku concluded when All Might said nothing. Katsuki rolled his eyes again.

“Listen, shitty Deku, I’m not going to act as your personal messenger while you’re in this ghost-like state, you hear me?”, he complained.

“But you’re the only one who can see me!”, Izuku protested, indignant. “We need to find a way to get me back into my body!”

“I don’t give a shit! I’m not a delivery boy, if you want to have your messages relayed, you get yourself a Ouija Board or something!”, he shouted at the boy, well aware that, for any outside viewer, it looked like he was shouting at thin air. He wasn’t really succeeding at not looking insane.

“What is Young Midoriya saying?”, All Might asked, and even though he still sounded like he thought Katsuki’s story was too unbelievable, there had been a shift in the look in his eyes that indicated there was a chance he was giving the boy a vote of confidence.

Katsuki groaned in annoyance at the question, knowing that, if he didn’t answer it, he would not only be seen as an uncooperative child, but his attitude would also be consistent with the one of a crazy person. He turned his head to look at ghost Deku, who had an expectant look on his face, and then to Deku’s body lying on the bed, still and pale. His eyes finally found Izuku’s mom, and the tear tracks on her cheeks, and even though the sight didn’t exactly soften his heart, he found himself unable to turn his back when he knew there were things he could do to help. What kind of hero would he be if he refused to aid those in need, even if it was shitty Deku with his annoying voice and wobbly lips?

“He said we should tell you something only he would know", Katsuki responded with a huff, not meeting All Might's eyes. He glimpsed at Deku only to find a wide smile on his face, gratitude etched in his expressive eyes. “Don’t look so smug, nerd", Katsuki growled with an annoyed look, turning his head so that he wouldn’t have to face that bright smile. “I’m only doing this so I can get rid of you faster”, he muttered, even though it ended up sounding half-hearted.

“I know”, Izuku agreed easily, and something about the way he agreed with that made Katsuki frown. “If I’m going to say something only I would know, it can’t be in front of my mom", he added pensively before Katsuki could try to read the look in his eyes. “You and All Might are the only ones who know about One For All, and she would freak out even more if she found out…”

“Then why don’t you just say something she would know about instead?”, Katsuki asked with an indifferent tone, shrugging.

“Kacchan!”, Izuku protested, eyes widening.

“What don’t I know about?”, Inko’s head shot up, eyes suddenly sharp with attention. “Mr. Toshinori?”, she turned her head to look for answers in All Might’s face when Katsuki didn’t answer her question.

“She can’t hear me, but she can hear you!”, Izuku said, sounding almost offended. Katsuki turned his head away from the boy, having the decency of looking embarrassed for his slip but putting on an angry scowl to hide that.

“Look, this isn’t easy, ok?!”, Katsuki argued defensively. “It’s really fucking hard to know what parts of your useless rambling I should tell them or not, and I told you I’m not a delivery boy. If you don’t want me to reply to the shit you say without thinking, then turn on your brain-to-mouth filter for once!”, he ended up yelling angrily again.

“Now, now, let’s all calm down, ok?”, All Might said, gesturing with his hands in an attempt to ease Katsuki’s increasingly sour mood.

“Don’t tell me to calm down, you bony bastard!”, Katsuki protested. “Just tell me how the fuck we can put Deku back into his shitty body so he can get the hell off my case!”

“You won’t be of any help if you keep yelling at people!”, Izuku snapped, annoyed with Katsuki’s familiar grumpiness.

“I won’t be of any help if you keep blabbering on my ear!”, Katsuki responded, so intense that his voice could probably be heard all over UA.

“Just tell my mom to go grab a coffee or something so that I can convince All Might I’m not really dead!”, Izuku shouted back.

“You tell All Might that yourself, you shitty nerd!”

“I would if I could, but unfortunately I’m stuck with you as my only way to communicate with people!”

“Well, and I’m stuck with you as the shittiest fucking ghost in the history of haunting!”

“What on earth is going on here?!”, a new voice entered their discussion, and Katsuki turned on his heels to find Recovery Girl standing at the door, Katsuki’s parents lurking anxiously behind her and trying to peek inside the room. He opened his mouth to answer, Izuku with a similar look beside him, but it was All Might who broke the silence.

“We apologize for the disruption, Chiyo", he said, walking past Katsuki in order to greet the small woman. “But there are some news I believe you need to know about”.

“The only thing I need to know is why one of my patients is out of bed, screaming like a spoiled child in the room of my other patient”, she replied angrily, glaring disapprovingly at Katsuki.

“I…”, Katsuki tried to say, obviously taken aback by the interruption, but All Might was faster than him once again.

“Young Bakugou believes there is a chance we might save Young Midoriya's life", he announced, and the way he said the words – sounding almost hopeful – differed so much from his disbelieving tone from just a few minutes before that the contrast made Katsuki frown.

However, Recovery Girl was not so easily convinced. Her face fell into something akin to pity and her shoulders slumped as she shook her head in disappointment.

“We talked about this, Toshinori", she said, sounding like she was scolding the symbol of peace. “The diagnosis has not changed –“

“I can see him", Katsuki interrupted before she could continue, looking more serious than he ever had in his life. Recovery Girl turned to him with a puzzled look. “Deku. He’s standing beside me right now", he added solemnly. Recovery Girl watched him with sharp eyes. “I know how this sounds", he continued, feeling the need to fill the uneasy silence in the room. “But I’m not crazy. I don’t know what happened, but for some reason, Deku is still around, and I’m the only one who can see him. Unfortunately", he added the last part with a twist of his nose, just because it had been a few seconds too long since he last teased the boy. He looked at Deku from the corner of his eyes to see his reaction, and found him biting his nails nervously, eyes glued on Recovery Girl’s tiny form.

“Tell them I think the villain’s quirk made my soul disconnect from my body", Deku had the audacity to phrase it as if Katsuki was there to obey his every command.

“Shut the fuck up, you damn nerd", Katsuki simply growled. “I told you I’m not your personal messenger”.

“I had my doubts as well”, All Might told the healing heroine, clearly trying to mediate the situation before Katsuki ended up sounding too much like a lunatic. “But, if you think about it, Young Bakugou’s story is not too impossible. Young Midoriya was hit with an unknown quirk, but he didn’t die”, he tried to argue.

“He is brain dead", Recovery Girl pointed out sternly, sparing Inko an apologetic look for her straightforwardness.

“Precisely!”, All Might exclaimed. “Why did his other organs not shut down?”

“Because Mrs. Midoriya refuses to turn the life support devices off", the healing heroine replied matter-of-factly. All Might sighed.

“Yes”, he sighed tiredly. “But what I mean is", he pointed at Midoriya’s body lying on the bed. “It is not impossible that the criminal’s quirk caused some sort of separation between Young Midoriya's body and his… soul, for the lack of a better word”.

“That’s what I said!”, Izuku exclaimed triumphantly. Katsuki felt the irresistible urge to punch the nerd in the face, but did nothing.

“So you really believe Bakugou sees and communicates with Midoriya’s… soul?”, Recovery Girl asked, one eyebrow perking up in disbelief.

“I didn’t put much faith in it, until I witnessed their discussion first hand", All Might explained, and Katsuki finally understood why the symbol of peace had finally stopped looking at him as if he was fit to be tied. “Though I could only hear Young Bakugou's side of the argument, it felt very similar to the conversations he usually shares with Young Midoriya. It did not look like the result of a hallucination, or of a similar condition”.

Recovery Girl clicked her tongue, looking at Katsuki with a pensive look and analyzing him from head to toe. After a few moments of silent assessment, she pulled a nearby chair towards the explosive boy and pushed him down on it without a word.

“What?!”, he asked, taken aback by the sudden course of action.

“Sit still", she commanded, fishing a tiny flashlight from her pocket and pointing it at Katsuki's eyes. The bright light made him flinch, and he heard Izuku hiss from somewhere behind him. After checking his pupils, Recovery Girl continued to examine him closely, testing his reflexes, checking his head injury and asking him a couple of questions to verify his cognitive abilities. By the end of it, Katsuki was fuming on the chair, putting an especial effort on not allowing the tiny explosions at the palm of his hands to become too massive. He hated being examined. He hated people touching him without a good reason.

“Well?”, All Might asked when Recovery Girl stepped away from Katsuki with a conclusive look on her face.

“His head injury looks better”, she announced. “He is still concussed, but it’s nowhere near as bad as when he arrived. He is aware of his surroundings and seems very lucid to me”, she sighed. “But there is still a chance he could be hallucinating. It is not unprecedented for people to see deceased loved ones after they die tragically. It’s a common symptom of trauma”.

“Deku is not a loved one!”, Katsuki immediately protested, unable to keep one of his hands from giving off a series of loud popping explosions at his urgency to defend himself. “And I’ve told you I am not traumatized! I’ve got no reason to be! I don’t give a shit about the damn nerd!”

Recovery Girl gave him a knowing look. Katsuki felt his stomach churn.

“I was the one who tended to you when you arrived last night", she said simply, calmly. “I know what I saw”.

“Ehhh?!”, Katsuki protested furiously, not understanding why the woman’s words pissed him off so much. “Then you're the one who’s batshit crazy, you old hag!”, he accused.

“Kacchan!”, Midoriya exclaimed, horrified.

“Bakugou!”, All Might reprehended indignantly, so furious at the boy's insolence that he puffed into his tall, muscular, All Might form. “It is not acceptable for you to disrespect an old lady like that!”

“Leave it, Toshinori", Recovery Girl said with indifference, pulling yet another chair closer to the boy and hopping onto it. Her tiny legs dangled from the seat. “Anger is also a common response to hearing the truths you don’t want to admit".

“Now you fucking listen to me –“ Katsuki stood up from his seat, pointing an angry finger at the impassive old woman.

“Now, now, Young Bakugou", All Might, still in his muscular form, grabbed Katsuki’s shoulder with more strength than necessary and pulled him back into his seat, holding him there.

“It's also one of the seven stages of grief”, Recovery Girl added simply, almost absentmindedly.

“I am not grieving the damn nerd!”, Katsuki protested.

“Denial is also one of the stages", she hummed pensively, paying the angry Katsuki in front of her no mind. She looked like she was trying to reach a conclusion.

“I’m not denying anything! I’m telling you that Deku is standing right here!”, he pointed at where Izuku was standing, even though he knew no one else could see him.

“There is one way to figure out whether Bakugou needs a psychiatric intervention, however”, she continued, as if Katsuki was as invisible as Izuku. She looked at All Might, a mysterious look on her face. After a few moments of staring at each other in silence, All Might reverted to his thin, bony form with a puff.

“Young Bakugou", he said firmly with a heavy sigh. There was anticipation in his tone. Katsuki turned to stare at him, the man's hand still pinned on his shoulder. “Can Young Midoriya hear us, even if he can’t talk to us?”

Katsuki turned to look at Deku, even though he already knew the answer. The boy nodded promptly.

“Yeah, he can hear you”, Katsuki scoffed.

All Might leaned forwards and whispered something in Katsuki’s ear. After a few seconds, he stood back up, giving the explosive boy a serious look.

“You must follow these instructions to the letter", he reinforced out loud, squeezing Katsuki’s shoulder pointedly.

“Even the whispering part?”, Katsuki groaned, complaining. All Might nodded.

“Everything", he confirmed. Katsuki groaned, sighed, rolled his eyes, and did all sorts of childish complaints before standing up from his chair and heading towards the door.

“Come on, nerd", he called when Izuku didn’t follow. Pushing the door open, he held it for Izuku, even though the boy could probably just phase through it in his ghost-like form.

“Where are we going?”, Izuku asked, nervous. He glanced back at his mother, who was still sitting at his bedside, holding one of her son's hands with an expectant, teary-eyed look on her face. He looked unwilling to leave her.

“Just shut up and follow me, asshole", Katsuki huffed out an angry breath. When Izuku remained glued to his feet, he rolled his eyes again and left the room, allowing the door to slowly close behind him. Izuku spared his grieving mother one final longing, conflicted look.

“I’ll be right back, mom", he promised before following Katsuki out.

“Kacchan! Wait!”, Izuku called after him as the explosive boy headed back to his own hospital room. He didn’t bother to deny his relief as he saw his parents were no longer there, having probably grown tired of waiting for his return from Izuku’s deathbed. Once Izuku stepped into the room after him, Katsuki closed the door and sat down on the bed, Izuku following him close and sitting beside him.

“Look", Katsuki said angrily – but when didn’t he sound angry? –, not meeting Izuku’s eyes or even bothering to look at him. “I’m just doing what All Might told me to do. And the only reason I'm doing this because the sooner we figure out what the hell is wrong with your nerdy ass, the sooner I’ll stop having to act as your personal assistant, you hear me?”, he huffed. Izuku lowered his eyes, a spark of disappointment flashing across his face.

“Alright, Kacchan", he agreed easily. “What did he tell you to do?”, he asked curiously.

If Izuku didn’t know better, if he hadn’t known that the person sitting beside him was Katsuki Bakugou, he would have sworn on his mother’s life that Kacchan was blushing. But there was no way that could be, right? If there was one person who never blushed, that person was Kacchan.

Katsuki leaned forwards towards Izuku, and the boy could feel his heart rate picking up, even though he was a mere astral projection. What the hell was Kacchan doing?! The explosive boy turned his head so that he could whisper something in Izuku’s ear and, despite knowing that this Izuku was nothing other than a ghost, a projection, an intangible spirit, Katsuki could have sworn he could feel the tickle of Izuku’s curly hair brushing against his cheek, at the same time Izuku could have sworn he felt the warmness of Katsuki’s breath making his neck tingle.

Katsuki hesitated for a few seconds, his lips hovering just beside Izuku’s ear.

“You need to activate One For All", he whispered, voice low and soft in a way that Izuku had never heard it in all the years they had known each other. Even if there had been anyone else in the room with them, no one other than Izuku would have been able to hear Katsuki’s words. Those words were meant for him and him alone.

Katsuki’s voice had always been as loud as his explosions. Now, it was soft and gentle like a breeze. Izuku had never thought such a sound was possible until he heard it firsthand, and it was endearing.

Izuku allowed his eyes to flutter close and the power of One For All flow through his body.

Once he was sure he had successfully activated his power, he stared down at his arms, but much to his surprise they looked as normal as ever. No bright lines crossing them. No green sparks. Nothing. He could feel One For All spreading across himself, but saw no signs of it. He turned his head to look at Katsuki, a confused frown on his face, only to find the same baffled look on his friend's face.

“Does that mean –“, Katsuki started, an unusual look of terror flashing in his eyes, but before he could finish that thought, a piercing scream made the two boys snap their heads towards the door.

“Izuku!”, Inko was screaming and sobbing from her son’s room.

“Midoriya, my boy!”, All Might shouted triumphantly.

Izuku and Katsuki turned their heads towards each other in perfect synchrony, eyes wide in anticipation. It was Katsuki who acted first, jumping off the bed and running back towards Izuku's room, only to find the boy's body still lying in the same position on the bed, but with green lightning enveloping his form. He had activated One For All.

“I’m alive”, ghost Izuku whispered from behind him, sounding more baffled than anything. Katsuki turned to face him, and Izuku met his eyes. “Kacchan, I’m still alive!”, he repeated emphatically, as if that information was a surprise to him. There was a wide smile blossoming on his lips.

“Heard you the first time, nerd", Katsuki bickered, turning his head away so that Izuku wouldn’t be able to see the tiny smirk that appeared on his own lips.

“Young Bakugou! You were right!”, All Might cheered, pulling Katsuki into a tight embrace. “Young Midoriya still lives!”

“Of course I was right", Katsuki growled, but didn’t break from All Might's embrace. “I told you I wouldn’t make something like this up".

“The fact that Midoriya managed to activate his power proves that he is not brain dead, and since he activated it away from his body after you instructed him to, we can assume you are not clinically insane”, Recovery Girl tapped Katsuki on the shoulder, as if congratulating him for not being a total nutcase. There was a hidden teasing in her voice. “However, I would still like to keep you under observation", she added mischievously. “You suffered a nasty head injury and lost way too much blood".

“I feel fine", Katsuki protested, even though it wasn’t quite true. He felt tired and achy, his headache getting increasingly worse by the second.

“I believe our priority should be figuring out what exactly happened to Midoriya, now that we know he is still around us", Recovery Girl announced. “However", she added, sending a knowing glance towards Katsuki as if reading his thoughts. “Mr. Bakugou is still recovering and shouldn’t have stayed so long out of bed. Go back to your room and get some rest", she instructed him. “I will go see you in a moment".

“But…”, Inko protested, tears running down her face. “If Izuku is alive… shouldn’t we… shouldn’t we work on making him better at once?”, she suggested meekly.

“We still don’t know what exactly happened to Young Midoriya. I will speak to Aizawa sensei and see if we can collect all the existing information on any possible quirks that could cause this”, All Might announced. He placed a comforting hand on Inko’s shoulder. “Mrs. Midoriya, I promise you that I will do everything in my power to bring your boy back”.

“Thank you", Inko sniffed and sobbed, jumping from her seat and pulling All Might into a tight hug which surprised even the man. “Oh, thank you! And thank you, Katsuki!”, she rushed to Katsuki’s side, pulling the boy into an equally tight embrace. He sighed, uncomfortable with all the uninvited touching he was having to go through on that day. “Thank you for helping my baby!”

“Yeah, yeah, whatever", he mumbled, glad to be released from the tight grasp as Inko took a step back, tears still running down her chubby cheeks. Katsuki looked away, not willing to face the greenness of her eyes. God, what was it about Midoriyas and their stupid fucking eyes? Katsuki wanted to say he hated them, but they evoked a completely different feeling, which seemed to be unnamable.

“To bed with you, now, Bakugou", Recovery Girl ordered him, actually pushing him towards the door. “You need all the rest you can get to recover and help us figure out how to help Midoriya. We will still have to make some research on the quirk affecting him, so you go catch some winks”.

“Fine”, he huffed simply. Without bidding any of them goodbye, or even looking back, he turned on his heels and left the room. Now that he stopped to think about it, and now that he was sure he wasn’t batshit, he could finally realize how ridiculously tired he was. He thought about asking Recovery Girl for some pain killers to help with the painful throbbing of his head, but the idea of having someone fussing over him at that moment wasn’t exactly endearing. He would probably be fine after he caught some sleep.

He hadn't expected Deku to follow him to his room.

“The fuck are you doing here?”, Katsuki asked, sparing Deku one quick, disinterested glance before throwing himself down on the bed and passing an arm over his eyes unceremoniously.

“I…”, Izuku hesitated for a moment, standing awkwardly in front of the bed. “I thought I’d check on you", he explained half-heartedly.

“Tch. Check on me? You’re the one with a foot in the grave", Katsuki scoffed. “Or a whole body, all things considered”.

“Yeah, but…”, Izuku swallowed dry. He dropped his head before gathering the courage to look up again. Most of Katsuki’s face was hidden away by his arm. “You should ask Recovery Girl some medicine for your headache”, he suggested finally, firmly.

“I don’t have a headache”, Katsuki lied in a flat tone without missing a beat.

“Yes, you do", Izuku argued as quickly.

“And how the fuck would you know that, shitty Deku?”, Katsuki scoffed, sounding tired and petulant. If anything, the throbbing in his head was killing him slowly and painfully, but he would never admit it out loud to anyone.

“I… just do", Izuku shrugged helplessly. Katsuki finally lifted his arm so that he could peek at the boy, suspicion etched all over his crimson eyes. He studied Izuku’s face for a long time before speaking up.

“The fuck you talking about?”, Katsuki asked, defensive. Izuku immediately blushed.

“Nothing! I j-just mean you keep squinting at the light and… and… your scowl looks worse than usual! And Recovery Girl said you took a bad hit, so it only makes sense your head would be hurting!”, he argued. Katsuki narrowed his eyes for a moment as if trying to figure out whether Izuku was lying, but ended up resting his head back on the pillow and throwing his arm over his face again.

“Whatever. I’ll just sleep it off", he said finally, as flatly as before.

“Kacchan –“, Izuku tried to protest.

“Listen, Deku", Katsuki sighed tiredly, keeping his arm over his eyes. He sounded uncharacteristically tired, but familiarly pissed off. “Just because I’m helping you doesn’t mean we're besties. That means we don’t get to braid each other’s hairs, we don’t get to talk about our feelings, we don’t get to have sleepovers, and you definitely don’t get to *fucking tell me what to do*. Are we clear?”

Izuku lowered his head, sighing. He looked to the side, a frustrated frown on his face.

“Yeah”, he said simply, sounding almost disappointed.

“Now shut the fuck up and let me sleep”, Katsuki added with a growl. “And don’t just fucking stand there and watch me napping like some creepy weirdo. Go find something else to do", he instructed.

“But no one else can see me", Izuku protested miserably. What was he supposed to do?

“Precisely. Go peek at the girls’ bathroom or something", Katsuki grinned. His mouth and the tip of his nose were the only visible parts of his face, since they weren’t buried on the crook of his arm.

“*Kacchan*!”, Izuku exclaimed, offended.

“I’m just teasing you, shitty Deku. I know you wouldn’t do that", if anything, Katsuki’s grin only widened at the protest. Izuku blushed, thankful that Kacchan wasn’t looking at him to see that.

“You wouldn’t, either”, he stated simply, not looking at Katsuki. Even though he had expected the words to come out as petty, they ended up sounding more meaningful than he

had first intended it.

“Nah", Katsuki responded simply, arm hiding his eyes from view. He said nothing else, and the subject dropped.

Long moments of silence passed, Izuku watching pensively as Katsuki’s breathing gradually evened out. He didn’t know whether the explosive boy was asleep or not when he decided to speak up again, approaching a matter that had been bothering him ever since Katsuki had first woken up in a lucid state.

“You really don’t remember what happened yesterday?”, Izuku asked, a melancholic tone in his voice. Katsuki sighed so loudly it sounded like a hiss.

“Fuck, you’re *still there*?”, he raised his eyebrows, as if surprised by Deku’s audacity to defy his order. “No, I fucking don’t. Just drop it. Remembering what happened or not won’t change the fact that you’re halfway dead", he scoffed. “No use living in the past”.

“Alright”, Izuku agreed simply. He didn’t know why Katsuki had forgotten, but maybe it was just a side effect to the head injury. Recovery Girl had said he was still concussed, after all.

Another series of silent moments passed, no other sound other than Katsuki’s breathing filling the room.

“Kacchan", Izuku called quietly after a while. Katsuki’s growl was animalistic.

“Oh my fucking god, I swear I’ll march down to your room and smother you to death with a hundred pillows if you don’t shut the fuck up right now, Deku”, he threatened in annoyance, covering his face with both hands and looking like it was taking every ounce of his self-control not to explode Izuku’s ghost into the afterlife.

“I just wanted to thank you", Izuku continued, unbothered by the violent display. In fact, he was almost used to it. “For, you know, helping me. I know you don’t want to. And… I know you don’t have to. So thanks", he said with sincerity.

“Of course I have to, you goddamn moron", Katsuki growled, turning abruptly and very exaggeratedly on the bed so that he would be lying on his side. It was almost as if he was trying to show Izuku that he wasn’t up to conversation. He placed his pillow on the top of his face in order to block the light from his sensitive eyes, and quite possibly to also block the sound of Izuku’s voice from his sensitive ears. He sighed before concluding: “What kind of hero would I be if I didn’t?”

Izuku watched him with adoration in his eyes. Katsuki continued to bury his face in the pillow, annoyed and unaware of the way Izuku was looking at him.

“Kacchan”, he whispered in admiration.

“Just let me fucking sleep, ok? This whole proving-I'm-not-a-basket-case thing tired me out", Katsuki grumbled grumpily, punching the remaining pillow beneath his head as if to soften it, before dropping heavily on it. “Go find someone else to bother and get the hell out of here".

Izuku lowered his head. He knew he wouldn't be able to go anywhere, even if he wanted to.

He stayed there in silence, sitting on the farthest corner of Katsuki's hospital room and very pointedly refusing to look at him. He failed to notice the way Kacchan's constant grimace was replaced by a peaceful, relaxed expression that was so unusual to see on his face, once he succumbed to deep slumber.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for the positive feedback on chapter one! I hope this one turned out well too! I may take some time to reply to the comments, but any and all feedback is welcomed!

Chapter 3: 'Cause Every Time We Touch, I Get This Feeling (That Makes Me Want To Punch You In The Face)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Katsuki woke up feeling dizzy and disoriented, having to dedicate a few moments of sluggish blinking to remember what had happened to him and where he was. He sighed heavily as the events of the past day became clear in his mind, groaning in discomfort and squeezing his eyes shut before reopening them. With a sigh, he turned on his side on the bed, ignoring the way his scalp stung ever so slightly at the movement. His head was still feeling hazy from sleep and the remains of his concussion and, for a moment, he feared everything he remembered had been nothing but some creepy, weird dream. However, as he spotted damn Deku in the bedroom with him, looking just as pale as Katsuki remembered last seeing him, he admitted to himself that everything had, indeed, and unfortunately, happened just as he recalled.

At the farthest corner of the room, Izuku sat, arms crossed above his chest and head low as he dozed off, standing vigil in Katsuki's room. His green bangs were hiding his freckled face away from view and his position on the cold, harsh floor looked uncomfortable, but his breathing was steady and slow. Katsuki clicked his tongue and let his head fall back against his pillow, looking at anything but the shitty nerd sitting on his floor.

"Idiot", he mumbled, voice hoarse from the lack of use. He felt just as thirsty as he had when he first woke up and heard the news from his parents, but this time, he wouldn't wait for anyone to do him favors. He kicked off his blankets – when had he covered himself with them? – and stood up from the bed, glad to find he didn't feel as dizzy as he had a few hours before. Or had it been a day? He couldn't really know. Glancing at the window beside the bed, Katsuki found the sky to be dark and covered by stars.

He walked over to a little round desk near the door in order to grab himself a cup of water from the jar sitting there. After downing a whole cup in one go and relishing on the feeling of having his throat soothed, Katsuki realized how badly he needed the bathroom, after staying in bed for god knows how long. Sparing the sleeping Deku one final look and a scoff that only half-attempted to be disdainful, he walked out of his hospital room and headed to the common bathroom on that floor, not consciously realizing that he clicked the door behind him as silently as he could.

Katsuki was more than startled when, after he did what he had to do in the bathroom, he stepped out only to find Deku sitting just outside, still looking very much asleep and in the exact same position as Katsuki had left him back in the bedroom. Staring at the boy for a few confused moments, Katsuki finally snorted through his nose and downright scowled at Izuku.

"What the fuck?", he said loudly, assuming Izuku was awake. He had to be, right? He had followed Katsuki all the way to the bathroom like a lovesick puppy! *Like he always does*, Katsuki's mind provided, but he waved the thought away. "The hell are you doing, Deku?

Not only I'm the being forced to deal with your annoying ass, but you're gonna follow me around all the time now, too?"

Izuku jolted awake at the loud sound of Katsuki's voice shouting at him, looking around frantically and in confusion before finding the blond boy standing angrily in front of him. His shoulders slumped in relief and he leaned back against the wall for a moment, heart racing inside his chest. After a few seconds of breathing heavily due to the startle of being shouted awake, Izuku frowned slightly, taking a more careful look around and opening his mouth several times as he struggled to find the words he wanted to say.

"… Kacchan?", he settled for saying, and honestly, why the *fuck* was that the first thing Izuku always chose to say to him? It was getting on Katsuki's nerves and doing weird things to his stomach. It was probably just anger, he told himself. "What happened?", the boy added hesitantly, not seeming to recognize his surroundings.

"What happened is that you decided to follow me all the way to the bathroom like some creepy son of a bitch", Katsuki provided, glaring at Deku as he slowly got to his feet and scratched the back of his messy hair in awe.

"Oh… So it works the other way around, too", he commented simply, eyes widening slightly before returning to normal, as if he had just reached an obvious, yet incredible conclusion.

Katsuki *hated* when he did that. He hated when he could see in Deku's eyes that he was unmasking secrets that Katsuki himself would never be able to figure out. It made a twisted mixture of admiration and envy sparkle and explode inside of him and, more often than not, he externalized the feeling as nothing other than pure fury.

"What the *fuck* do you mean by that, you shitty nerd? Just spit out whatever weird ass reason you had to follow me before I punch your teeth in", he barked in his usual furious tone. Izuku flinched – flinching when Kacchan screamed at him was muscle memory, even if their dynamics had changed, now – and lowered his head before seeming to remember he didn't have to cower down because of Katsuki anymore. Lifting his head up with bravery, but still bearing an apologetic look on his face, Izuku offered an explanation.

"While you were asleep the first time, I couldn't get too far away from the bedroom", he said. "I told you that. I was drawn to you like a magnet".

"Which doesn't make any fucking sense", Katsuki pointed out, ignoring the way his chest felt weird at the way Izuku phrased it. *Probably anger.*

"I agree, and I don't know why this keeps happening, either", he nodded his head, his eyes assuming that distant look they always did whenever Izuku got lost in deep thought. "But either way, I never managed to get too far away from you. I thought it only happened when I was the one who tried to get away from you, but it seems that the same happens when you're the one who tries to get away from me", he explained, and *fuck*, Katsuki could literally feel the blood being drained from his face at the words. "I didn't even feel myself getting dragged behind you until you woke me up – I'm – I'm sorry, Kacchan", he added, noticing the horrified/angry look that was taking over the boy's pale face.

“So you’re saying”, Katsuki started. His voice was hoarse, there was a vein popping on his temple, and it looked like it was taking him every ounce of his self-control not to blow the entire medical bay up as he spoke the words through gritted teeth, hands squeezed into fists that were barely containing the explosions in his palms. “That I can’t get away from you. Even if I try to”, he concluded, snarling.

“I – I really don’t know”, Izuku raised his hands at him as if trying to calm a feral animal. “But I think so. I’m sorry, I – I don’t know how this works”.

“So not only I’m the only one who can see and talk to your annoying ass”, he repeated his words from before, teeth still gritted and vein threatening to explode beside his head, “but I’m stuck with you 24/7?”

“I w-wouldn’t phrase it like that”, Izuku tried to offer meekly, a small, hesitant smile appearing on his lips as if he was attempting to make Katsuki see the bright side of things. As if there *was* a bright side of things in the first place. “I mean, I can get a few feet away from you before I get pulled back. So, when you go to the bathroom or – or when you need some p-privacy, I won’t pry, I swear, Kacchan”, he promised. Katsuki had to smother the need to punch the wall behind Deku’s head and quite possibly Deku’s head with it.

“Oh, so it’s all settled now? You won’t watch me as I change my clothes like some sort of Grape-Boy-like freak, so it’s all good, eh?”, he spat out sarcastically, taking a step closer to Deku. “Who cares if I wish I could be a fucking *planet* away from you, at least you won’t peek while I take a shit! God fucking damn it, Deku, I swear to god there’s no way this whole situation isn’t a fucking nightmare”, he growled. Izuku looked slightly hurt, but mostly offended, at the words.

“As I told you before, I’m – I’m not loving this either”, Izuku said, frowning and looking braver than he had a mere moment before. His knees were still a bit wobbly, as if he was trying to force himself to be strong, but he tilted his chin up defiantly. “Until we figure out a way to p-put me back in my body, I’m afraid we’ll… We’ll have to find a way to deal with each other”.

“I don’t want to *deal* with you, damn Deku!”, Katsuki all but shouted, ignoring the fact that he was standing in the middle of the hall of Recovery Girl’s medical bay, and to any outside viewer, he was alone, since no one else could see Deku. “I never fucking wanted to do that and I certainly don’t want to now!”

“Well, I’m sorry, but you’ll have to!”, Izuku argued, taking a step closer to Katsuki in defiance. He was no longer shaking. “You said it yourself. The sooner you help me, t-the sooner I’ll leave you alone, right? So just deal with me for a couple of days and then I’ll be out of your case!”

“A couple of days is two days longer than I’m willing to look at your dunce face!”, Katsuki protested. “Fuck!”, he shoved his sweaty hands on his hair, throwing it back in annoyance. “Of all the fucking people in the world, it had to be you, hadn’t it?”, he scowled. Izuku closed his mouth, but stared at Katsuki with an offended frown.

“Sorry for saving your life, Kacchan”, he ended up saying after a few moments of silence, sounding hurt and frustrated. “I wish I could say next time I’ll let you get hit, but we both know that’s not true”.

The words only made Katsuki fume further, and shit, the vein in his temple would definitely burst now, from the way his whole face scrunched up in indignant fury. One of his hands set off an explosion that turned out a bit bigger than Katsuki was comfortable with in a closed environment.

“What the *fuck* do you think you’re saying, nerd?”, he all but snarled, hands tightening into fists. “I don’t know what you heard from that old hag and bony Might, but you didn’t fucking *save my life*”, he looked ready to attack Izuku at any moment now, even though the boy was a ghost. “I don’t fucking *need* you to save my life. I *never* needed that”, he shook his head and pointed a finger at Izuku, remembering the incident with the slime monster. It felt like it had happened decades ago. “So shut the hell up and forget whatever it was these people shoved into your potato brain. I don’t owe you anything”, he snorted. “I don’t fucking *owe* you anything, Deku”, he repeated for good measure. Izuku stared at him with an unreadable expression.

“I know you don’t”, he replied simply, looking uncomfortable. “I’m – I’m not charging you, Kacchan”.

“It sure as hell sounds like you are”, Katsuki pointed out with a scoff. Izuku simply sighed, allowing his shoulders to slump in resignation and turning his head to the side.

“Look”, he said after a few more moments, sounding tired and… something else that Katsuki didn’t really understand. Comprehension, perhaps? “I’m just saying everything will be easier if we cooperate with each other. You don’t want to be stuck with me, and I don’t want to be disconnected from my body. We have the same goal”, he shrugged, “which is finding a way to fix this. If we work together, I’m sure we can do it, Kacchan”.

“Cut this positivity bullshit”, Katsuki gave Izuku one final snort before turning on his heels abruptly and heading back towards his bedroom. He was surprised no one had rushed over to see why he was shouting and setting off explosions in the middle of the night; he didn’t want to push his luck and be caught by Recovery Girl.

As he marched back, he didn’t bother to see if Izuku was following him, now aware that, even if the boy didn’t want to tag along, he would be forced to, since they were stuck with each other for some reason.

“Let’s just find a way to shove your shitty soul up your ass and make sure it sticks in there before you drive me really nuts this time”, he said above his shoulder after a while. Izuku’s eyes widened and a vigorous blush made its way to his freckled cheeks.

“*Kacchan*!”, Izuku protested at the aggressive – and very graphic – description Katsuki had just given.

“What? You said it yourself that’s our common goal”, Katsuki grinned wickedly, turning his head so that Izuku wouldn’t be able to see it.

“Not with those words!”, Izuku pointed out nervously, catching up with Katsuki and reentering the room alongside him.

“Whatever, nerd”, Katsuki scoffed, slamming the door shut and heading back towards his bed. He sat down on it cross-legged, a pensive look on his face. Izuku liked it when Kacchan was pensive. He often came up with great ideas and the anger was smoothed out of his face when he dedicated his attention to his thoughts. He stood in front of Katsuki, an awkward look on his face and clearly not knowing what to do with himself, as the boy continued to stare at nothing in particular. “We’re gonna need to stablish some ground rules if I’m gonna be forced to do this”, Katsuki finally said after a while, giving Izuku a serious look as he leaned back on his arms. “First – no peeking. If I tell you not to look at something, you’re not fucking looking. The list of things I don’t even need to tell you not to fucking look at includes, but is not limited to: me going to the bathroom, me changing clothes, me sleeping, me showering, and whatever shit is too personal to have your creepy nerd eyes all over me. Clear?”, he raised an eyebrow at Izuku.

“K-Kacchan, w-why would I want to watch y-you shower –“, Izuku stuttered nervously, face flushing a bright red.

“Shut up, Deku!”, Katsuki interrupted. “Second – no. Fucking. Mumbling. I swear to fucking god, if I have to deal with your shitty mumbling sessions at all times every fucking day, I will make sure you won’t have a body to return your soul to. You get it?”

“But I…”, Izuku tried to protest sadly, but ended up lowering his head. “Fine, I get it”, he accepted with resignation.

“Third – I’m not your personal fucking assistant. I’m not gonna relay your messages or have whole conversations in your place just because you’re a shitty ghost, now. If you have something important to say that you think can help you get the hell back where you belong and leave me the fuck alone, then go ahead and say it, but otherwise you’re gonna zip it and keep your thoughts to your shit-brain. You hear me?”

“So basically you want me to close my eyes, shut my mouth and just follow you around silently without doing or saying anything until we figure out a way to put me back into my body?”, Izuku asked with a frown, sounding slightly offended. Katsuki simply grinned widely.

“Bingo”, he smirked. “You can go ahead and start training, now. Go stare at that wall over there and count down from a hundred billion while I take another nap and figure out what the hell to do about you. Good luck”, he nodded at Izuku, unceremoniously hopping down on the bed and lying back down again. “And count it in your *head*, Deku, not out loud. Remember rule number two”, he advised.

“You’re… going to sleep again, Kacchan?”, Izuku asked with a frown, completely ignoring most of what Katsuki had said and sounding actually concerned. Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“What is it to you? It won’t interfere with your counting”, he said simply, bitter. Izuku took a step closer to the bed.

“I’m not counting”, he said simply, but waved the thought away quickly enough. “It’s just… I mean, you’ve been sleeping for almost a day, now”, Izuku explained, worried. “I think you should talk to Recovery Girl –“

“Rule four”, Katsuki interrupted him before he could continue. “No shoving your nose on things that aren’t your damn business”.

“It *is* my business!”, Izuku immediately protested. “You’re my f–“, he started, but cut himself off midway as if thinking better about what he was about to say. He looked away from Katsuki, embarrassed, and hesitated for a few moments before continuing. Katsuki eyed him with a curious, yet impassive glance. “You're… Well. I… I don’t think you should be sleeping this much”, he settled for saying, sounding like he was hiding something.

“I only have to sleep this much because you tire me the fuck out”, Katsuki rolled his eyes, even though he was still suspicious of Deku’s odd behavior. “Now shut the hell up and get started on that counting".

“Kacchan, I’m serious”, Izuku said with a tired sigh, looking frustrated. He didn’t meet Katsuki’s eyes. “You should be getting better already”, he added in a low voice.

“Who says I’m not?”, Katsuki raised an eyebrow at Izuku, arms folded beneath his head in a carefree way.

“I can tell you aren’t”, Izuku shook his head, worrying at his lower lip. “Just - Just promise me you’ll talk to Recovery Girl in the morning, ok? Y-You took a nasty hit to the head, it’s better to be safe than sorry”.

Katsuki eyed him silently for several moments, but Izuku didn’t properly look at him until he spoke up.

“You know, Deku”, Katsuki growled through gritted teeth, looking angry and slightly disgusted. “One of the things I hate the most about you is your shitty, unjustifiable god complex. You’re always going around, meddling with things that aren’t your business and expecting people to be grateful and lick your boots for shoving your nose where you aren’t called. Guess what?”, he scoffed. “I don’t fucking need you to save me, and I definitely don’t need you to go around with that smug look on your ugly face as if you’re some sort of god sent savior or some shit. So just get over yourself and deal with the fact that you’re not fucking better than me, and you *never* will be", he shrugged.

There was a pregnant silence in which Izuku simply stared at him, mouth hanging open and eyes looking sad and unexplainably hurt. Katsuki opted to ignore his kicked-puppy look and turned on the bed so that his back was turned to the boy.

“You… really think *that* of me?”, Izuku asked miserably after an eternity, voice small and wobbly. Katsuki sighed heavily and rolled his eyes, even though Izuku couldn’t see it.

“Yeah. Now shut your damn mouth and let me take my nap in peace. And you’d better not stare at me while I sleep", he reminded the boy, ignoring the way Izuku had sounded as if he was about to burst into tears like a crybaby.

“Kacchan, I would never… I… I don’t think…”, Izuku started, but before Katsuki could even complain, or protest his words, or turn to glare at him, he trailed off on his own, lowering his head in disappointment and letting out a shaky breath before sitting on the floor, back as turned to Katsuki as Katsuki’s back was turned to him.

None of them spoke another word for an eternity. Katsuki was on the verge of succumbing to the deep, pleasant slumber that had been overcoming him when he heard a tiny, barely audible “Goodnight, Kacchan", which sounded a bit drier than usual.

Katsuki didn’t reply, even if his chest felt weirdly constricted for some reason.

When he woke up, the first thing he saw was shitty red hair and a smile that was way too wide for that early hour in the morning.

“Bakugou! You’re awake!”, Kirishima exclaimed happily as soon as crimson eyes focused on him, voice a bit too loud for Katsuki’s sensitive ears. He suppressed the urge to punch Kirishima's sharp teeth in, only because the boy seemed ridiculously happy to see him awake.

“For fuck’s sake, tone it down a million, Shitty Hair", Katsuki complained through gritted teeth, shoving his arm into the crook of his arm to block the brightness of the light filling his equally sensitive eyes. “The fuck you doing here?”, he growled grumpily.

“We came to see you!”, Kirishima replied in the same excited tone from before, but he had lowered his voice upon Katsuki's request. The plural pronoun made Katsuki frown in confusion before he removed his face from behind his arm and found, in horror, Discount Pikachu, Raccoon Eyes and Tape Guy standing behind Kirishima, all bearing very excited looks on their faces. “Recovery Girl said you’re finally allowed to get visitors, since you’re being cleared out soon! So the Bakusquad decided to stop by and see how their grumpiest member was doing after such a nasty concussion!”, Kirishima explained.

“Pay up, Sero", Mina instructed, offering the boy her outstretched hand without taking her eyes off Katsuki. “He didn’t punch Kirishima in the first ten seconds”.

“That’s not fair!”, Sero protested, even though he shoved his hand in his pocket and handed Mina the payment of their bet. “He’s still kind of sleepy. Just give it some time and I'm sure –".

“Shut up, idiot!”, Katsuki immediately protested, angry. “I’m not sleepy!”

“Ah, there he is!”, Kaminari jested, much to Katsuki's increasing dismay. Not only did he have to deal with shitty Deku, now these jackasses thought they could mock him?

“And I fucking told you to stop calling yourselves ‘Bakusquad', it’s ridiculous and fucking embarrassing!”, Katsuki continued his shouting session, glad to realize he was already feeling

much better and well-rested than he had in the night before, even if his eyes were still a bit sensitive to light and loud sounds made his head throb.

“Ah, don’t pretend you don’t like it we named our friend group after you", Mina rolled her eyes, dangerously indifferent to Katsuki's natural rage. “You love being the center of attention”.

“That’s because you’re all a bunch of extras, so it wouldn’t make sense to name the group after anyone but me", he scowled at the pink girl, who very maturely showed him her tongue. “It doesn’t mean it’s any less ridiculous".

“You know you love us”, Mina said simply, throwing her phone in the air and snapping a picture so quickly it threw everyone off their guards. “Surprise selfie with concussed Bakugou!”, she announced, laughing.

“*Eeh*?!”, was the only thing Katsuki could muster as a response before Mina snapped the picture and caught him frowning mid-scowl. The way Recovery Girl had wrapped a bandage around his head injury made his hair look ridiculous, and the way Mina had managed to capture his face right before it became fully twisted in indignation only added to the comic aspect of the selfie. She was laughing loudly as she showed the photo to Kaminari, but Katsuki, on the other hand, was kicking off his blankets and throwing himself off the bed.

“Delete that, Raccoon Eyes!”, he hollered, making the girl yelp and immediately flee the medical room without thinking twice, phone clutched tightly in her hands. “I’ll kill you!”, Katsuki screamed, trying to chase after her.

“Run, Mina!”, Kaminari shouted after the girl, while Sero doubled over from laughing and Kirishima tried to hold Katsuki back. “Run for your life!”

“Let go, Shitty Hair!”, Katsuki fumed beneath Kirishima's grasp, looking furious. “I’ll kill her and you're next on the line!”

“Kacchan, you should get back to bed!”, Izuku protested from somewhere in the bedroom, and Katsuki snapped his head back to find the boy standing at the opposite side of his bed, looking very worried. Had he been there all along? “You’re going to make your head worse!”, Izuku added pleadingly.

“What did I fucking say about minding your own business, shitty Deku?”, he pointed an angry finger at Izuku, redirecting his anger towards the boy since Kirishima wouldn’t let him go after Mina and shove her phone down her throat.

“Holy shit", Sero whispered from behind him, all humor gone from his voice. Katsuki turned around, hating the way he could feel a blush rising to his cheeks, and pointing his three remaining friends with very intense glares that dared them to call him crazy.

“*What*?”, Katsuki asked sharply, snarling. Kaminari and Sero took an instinctive step back, but Kirishima continued to stand by him, one of his hands still holding his forearm.

“You're… You’re really seeing him?”, Kaminari was the one who verbalized the question they were all asking themselves, a half-dumbfounded, half-terrified expression on his face. “Midoriya?”, he explained, as if he thought Katsuki might not understand who he was talking about. Katsuki felt like giving him a flying kick.

“All Might explained the situation to us before Recovery Girl let us in", Kirishima stepped in before Katsuki could do anything, “But… I don’t know. I guess we weren’t so sure”, he shrugged almost apologetically. Katsuki pointed him with a sharp glare.

“What, you all thought I *lost my mind* because of the fucking head injury?”, Katsuki asked with disdain. “Get in line, assholes. *Everyone* thought that”, he scoffed.

“But, I mean…!”, Kaminari exclaimed, looking improperly excited. “You can see and talk to him when no one else can! How cool is that?!”

“Not at all, dude", Sero nudged Kaminari’s side warningly, earning a confused look from the electric boy. “Midoriya almost died. Technically, he’s a ghost, now. And Bakugou is the only one he can talk to”, he added with a grimace. Kaminari’s eyes widened in realization and he hissed.

“Oh, no”, he groaned in sympathy.

“Yeah. Poor Midoriya”, he groaned, shaking his head grievously.

“*What*?!”, Katsuki shouted in indignation. “*I’m* the one who’s stuck with him! How is he the poor one, you seaweed-haired bastard?!”, he surged towards Sero with murderous intent, Kirishima holding him back again.

“He’s stuck with you too!”, Sero tried to explain nervously, cowering behind Kaminari and using him as a shield. “It works both ways!”

“He’s right, you know”, Izuku mumbled from where he was still standing, but Katsuki paid him no mind and the others couldn’t hear him.

“I’ll let you know it’s a *fucking pleasure* to be stuck with me, you goddamn stupid son of a bitch! I’m fucking amazing!”, Katsuki screamed violently.

“Clearly", Kirishima said under his breath, earning a giggle from Izuku. Katsuki turned abruptly to face the ghost boy.

“You think this is funny, shitty nerd?! You got something to say?! Huh?!”, he shouted. Kaminari, Kirishima and Sero’s eyes darted nervously from Katsuki to the empty spot he was staring at.

“This is so weird, man", Kaminari was the one who commented. “I mean, it looks like you’re talking to the wall. If All Might hadn’t told us about what happened, I'd definitely think you’ve gone nuts”.

“Like I said, get in line", Katsuki scoffed, sitting back down on his bed and glaring at his friends. He hated this situation. He hated that he was the only one who could see and talk to

shitty Deku, he hated that he looked like a lunatic whenever he spoke to shitty Deku, he hated that shitty Deku had gotten them in this situation in the first place. Rubbing his face with a tired hand, he sighed, desperate to change the subject to something that wasn't *shitty Deku* for once. "So the old lady said I'm going to get cleared out?", he raised an eyebrow at them.

"Soon", Kirishima nodded. "But she didn't say when. How are you holding up anyway, man? We were super worried about you".

"Yeah, when Uraraka and Iida came back and Aizawa sensei showed up all covered in blood, we all freaking lost it", Kaminari offered. "Especially after we saw the scene you made at the emergency room".

Katsuki sighed loudly and threw his head back in exasperation, ignoring the way it made the cut in his scalp sting. Why did everyone keep going back to that fucking subject? Couldn't they just drop it? Recovery Girl had said something about tending him and knowing what she had seen, and now Dunce Face was talking about it too as if his arrival at the medical bay had been some sort of big event. What the fuck had he done anyway? He couldn't remember anything that happened after they found the villain in the alleyway, and not knowing something that everyone else did was quite frankly driving him mad.

"Listen, I don't know what the fuck you all are talking about", he admitted, keeping his angry façade up as if to let his friends know that, even though he was admitting he didn't know something, it didn't mean they were any better than him. "Everyone keeps talking about what I did or didn't do, but the last thing I remember is fighting that shitty villain during the training and that's it", he looked up at Kirishima, knowing that, since he was Katsuki's closest friend, he would probably be able to read, just by looking at his eyes, the request he wasn't willing to verbalize. *Just tell me what the hell happened, since no one else will*.

Kirishima read Katsuki's eyes with close attention, trying to decipher the look etched in crimson. After a few moments, he looked back at Kaminari and Sero, who were still standing behind him, unaware of the silent exchange.

"Hey", Kirishima said, feigning absent-mindedness. "Uh, Mina's been gone for a while, right?"

"Of course", Kaminari giggled. "She took a photo of Bakugou in a hospital room. She's probably all the way across the world already".

"Or she's just visiting Midoriya in the next room, like she said she would", Sero added with a shrug.

"Why don't we all go see Midoriya, then?", Kirishima offered with a bright smile. "Bakugou can see him, but we can't. I'm sure he'd like us to visit".

"I really would, even if I'm not actually there! Thank you, Kirishima-kun!", Izuku commented from behind Katsuki, the excitement in his voice indicating that he had completely misread Kirishima's intention. Katsuki didn't even have to look at the brat to know there was a wide smile painting his face.

“You really are an idiot", Katsuki huffed, not bothering to look at the boy as he spoke. Kirishima gave him an indignant look.

“Hey!”, he protested.

“Wasn’t talking to you", Katsuki replied with indifference, clicking his tongue. Kirishima stared at the empty space behind Katsuki with a puzzled look but, finding nothing, turned back towards his friends.

“Anyway”, Kirishima continued with a nervous smile. “Why don’t you two go ahead to Midoriya’s room? I’ll be right behind you, I just gotta give Bakugou some of the chocolate Recovery Girl asked me to", he lied. Kaminari frowned.

“But we didn’t even see Recovery Girl today”, he pointed out. Kirishima stared at him with a disbelieving look and an awkward silence took over the room, until Katsuki broke it by grunting and grabbing his pillow, furious at Kirishima's shitty skills at lying.

“Just get the fuck out of here, Dunce Face!”, he screamed, launching the pillow at Kaminari with his full strength.

“Aah!”, Kaminari yelped in terror right before the pillow hit him square in the face. Losing balance, he almost fell on his butt, but Sero grabbed him and propped him up by the elbow, helping him stay on his feet.

“Let's go, Denki”, Sero said, urging the boy towards the door of Katsuki’s room as he spared Kirishima a silent, comprehending look.

“That was mean, Kacchan", Izuku commented almost sadly from the other side of the bed. “They came to visit you, you shouldn’t kick them out like that”, he added reprehensively. Katsuki rolled his eyes, opting to ignore the boy.

“See you later, then, Kiri”, Kaminari waved at the pair sadly, Sero’s hand still nudging him gently, albeit a bit urgently, towards the door.

“I’ll catch up with you guys in a sec!”, Kirishima shouted after them just before Sero closed the door with a knowing glance. As soon as they were gone, Kirishima immediately turned to Katsuki. “Fine”, he said simply, sitting on the bed beside his friend. “What do you want to know?”

“Let’s start with the reason why everyone keeps acting as if they know something I don’t when they talk about *whatever the hell* happened at the fucking medical bay", Katsuki snorted, sitting cross-legged on the bed. Kirishima clicked his tongue and looked away, looking pensive.

“Kacchan, maybe –“, Izuku tried to say but, unaware of his presence, Kirishima started to speak.

“Ah. Ok, I think it’s better if I start from the beginning", he shrugged, shifting on the bed so he could face Katsuki better. “So, everyone got worried when you and Midoriya disappeared,

right? You guys weren't answering the coms and you were gone forever, but I guess everyone just assumed the radio silence was because you were probably at each other's throat or something. Not even Aizawa sensei thought much of it until we heard Midoriya's SOS message", he explained. Katsuki groaned loudly.

"I asked what happened at the medbay, not a full-on mission report, hair for brains", he protested with impatience. Kirishima ignored him.

"Anyway, Ochako, Iida, and Todoroki were the first ones to get to your location, along with Aizawa sensei. They… they were pretty shocked when they came back. Even Aizawa sensei wasn't… Well, you know how he is, but even he was different. None of us really saw you or Midoriya arrive, you were sent straight away to Recovery Girl and we were still at the training waiting area. We were told to go back to the dorms and wait there, but when Ochako and the others came back… she spilled everything", he gave Katsuki an almost apologetic look. "She said Midoriya was… dead, or halfway there anyway, and that you were in shock because you had watched everything happen and…", he grimaced in anticipation for Katsuki's reaction.

"*What*? Just say it!", Katsuki urged when his friend hesitated for too long. Kirishima winced, but continued.

"She said Midoriya had died because he took the villain's blow in your place", Kirishima offered in a small voice, definitely hesitant and almost apologetic. Katsuki fumed.

"*This* shit again?!", he protested in rage. "I already told everyone that's not what happened!"

"Didn't you just say you don't remember anything from after you met the villain?", Kirishima asked, a genuinely confused frown on his face. This only made Katsuki angrier, because it was true. He didn't remember what had happened. He didn't remember if the shitty nerd had really saved him or not.

But the scarce possibility that he had made Katsuki *furious*.

"Just shut the hell up and continue the story!", Katsuki shouted, not willing to admit he was contradicting himself.

"How can he continue the story if he shuts up, Kacchan?", Izuku asked from behind him, and the glare Katsuki directed him was so intense that it could have burned holes through Izuku's very soul.

"Anyway", Kirishima continued before Katsuki had the chance to tell Deku to go fuck himself. "No one really bought the part of you being in shock, but everyone freaked out at Midoriya dying, so we waited until Aizawa sensei was gone from the dorms and sneaked out to Recovery Girl's bay so we could see what had really happened. Ochako and Iida stayed back, they were so distraught, but Todoroki came along. When we got there…", he trailed off again, earning an annoyed sigh from Katsuki.

"Are you going to keep making these dramatic pauses every time you've got something important to say, dumbass?", he asked with a scoff.

“Kacchan", Izuku said, a warning in his voice. Something about the way he said the name made Katsuki look at him again. He read Izuku, finding something akin to worry and fear in his ridiculously green eyes, urgency written all over his body. He swallowed dry a couple of times, as if gathering courage to speak. “I don’t think you should –“, he tried to say, but unaware of Izuku’s words or his interruption, Kirishima continued.

“You were freaking out", he said sternly, giving Katsuki a hesitant look, “when we got there. And I’m not saying usual-Bakugou-angry freak out session, I’m saying I-just-saw-someone-die-for-me freak out session. It was pretty scary", he added, looking pale.

“Huh?”, Katsuki asked, Izuku forgotten behind him as he focused his entire attention on what Kirishima was saying.

“No one knew what to do", Kirishima continued, speaking faster as if he just wanted that subject to get dealt with as soon as possible. “You were fighting everyone who tried to touch you and you were bleeding out. You nearly exploded Aizawa sensei’s hand when he tried to grab you. In the end, All Might had to hold you down in his muscular form and… uh…”, he hesitated again, scratching the back of his neck. “You – you started crying", he said, not meeting Katsuki's eyes.

“*What*?!”, Katsuki asked, mortified.

“Look, if it makes you feel any better, it didn’t *look* like you were crying”, Kirishima added quickly, as if sensing Katsuki’s growing rage. “Most of the class thought you were just screaming or… lashing out. You started to apologize to All Might but no one could understand anything you were saying, so before anyone else saw your tears I kicked them out with Todoroki’s help", he said.

“You let that Half’n’Half bastard see me *cry*?!”, Katsuki protested, furious. Kirishima raised his hands as if trying to calm a feral animal.

“He didn’t tell anyone! I made him promise he wouldn’t”, Kirishima reassured him. “And he was there for Midoriya, not you, so he didn’t think too much of it”.

“How fucking reassuring”, Katsuki growled sarcastically, turning to face Izuku. “What about you? Were you there too?”, he asked, a bit too aggressively.

“Y-Yes”, Izuku nodded hesitantly, looking nervous. “But Kacchan, I swear –“

“So you saw this whole shitshow?”, he interrupted, getting angrier by the second. “You saw everything and you didn’t *fucking tell* me about it?”

“You wouldn’t have believed me if I did!”, Izuku pointed out with exasperation. “Plus, what good would it be if I told you? It wouldn’t change anything that happened and it would have only made you embarrassed”.

“The *good* would be that I would have been able to make up some sort of excuse as to why I freaked out over *you*!” Katsuki shouted. “Now everyone thinks I give a shit about your whiny ass!”.

Izuku paused, staring at Katsuki in disbelief for a moment.

“And that’s just terrible for you, isn't it?”, Izuku retorted, much to Katsuki's surprise, eyes clearly hurt and glistening. “We’ve known each other since we were four, but god forbid people assume you care about me", he mumbled.

“Yeah, because I *don’t*!”, Katsuki growled. “I was probably crying because of the head injury, not because you’re a simple-minded bastard who almost got himself killed by a D-lister!”, he shouted.

“Bakugou”, Kirishima reprehended, even though he was only hearing one side of the conversation.

“Well, too bad, Kacchan, because *I* care about *you*!”, Izuku shouted back with tears in his eyes, sounding frustrated. “I always did and I always will, no matter how many times you step on me or put me down! I know you think horrible things of me, and I don’t know what I could have possibly done to make you think them, but I thought we had cleared things up after our fight! Apparently, I was wrong, since you continue to see me as this horrible, fake person, while, to me, you're nothing less than the very incarnation of victory!”

“Bakugou, he did take the blow for you”, Kirishima said, completely unaware of everything Izuku was saying. Katsuki turned his head towards the red-haired boy. “We saw the footage with Aizawa sensei”.

A long silence stretched in the room, awkward and tense. Katsuki didn’t dare to look at Izuku. He didn’t dare to breathe.

“What?”, he asked lowly, voice hoarse.

“Aizawa sensei let me and Todoroki watch the footage video with Recovery Girl”, Kirishima explained, one of his hands still reaching to Katsuki as if attempting to calm him. “I’m telling you I saw it with my own eyes. You knocked the villain down, but he was about to strike you and you didn’t see it. Midoriya did”.

Katsuki turned his head to face Izuku, who had his head bowed and tilted away so that Katsuki could see nothing other than pursed lips and freckled cheeks.

“He shoved you out of the way, which was how you got concussed. He jumped at you so hard you slammed your head on a wall”, Kirishima continued, following Katsuki’s gaze for a moment before setting his eyes back on the blond boy's face. “And the villain’s quirk hit him on the back. You were out cold for more or less three minutes, then you woke up and shoved him off you. It took you some time to realize he…”, he took a harsh intake of breath, looking at the empty spot beside Katsuki again. “Well”.

Katsuki continued to look at Izuku, whereas Izuku continued not to look at him.

“I didn’t tell anyone about it”, Kirishima reassured him after a few moments of silence, assuming that was the reason behind Katsuki’s unusual quietness. “Todoroki won’t, either. Aizawa sensei gave the rest of the class a summarized version of the story, and left out the

unnecessary details. All they know is that Midoriya got hit by a quirk that detached his soul from his body, since apparently that's… what happened".

Katsuki continued to stare at Izuku.

"Uh…", Kirishima hesitated, at a loss for what to do upon his friend's unfaltering silence. Seeing Katsuki stare at nothing like that was freaking him out a bit, if he was being honest. "I… Are you okay?"

"Why didn't you just say something?", Katsuki asked, apparently snapped out of whatever trance he had been stuck in by Kirishima's question. Izuku shifted awkwardly on his feet.

"I didn't want you to know", Izuku said quietly. His head was still hanging low, eyes refusing to meet Katsuki's as his green bangs hid them away from view.

"Why not?", Katsuki asked. He still sounded angry, but also softer, somehow. Kirishima's eyes darted between Katsuki and the empty space Katsuki was staring at, a worried frown etched on his brow.

"You didn't need to bear this burden", Izuku whispered. Katsuki stared at him for a few more moments before scoffing and shaking his head.

"What the *fuck* are you talking about, shitty Deku?", he snarled, voice very low and menacing. "Why would having you act as an unsolicited human shield be a burden to me, *eh*?", he asked, sounding just a bit too defensive.

"Bakugou… don't do that", Kirishima sighed heavily and shook his head in disapproval.

"I didn't want you to blame yourself for what happened!", Izuku protested in a high-pitched voice, equally defensive. Katsuki finally threw himself off the bed in rage, taking an angry stomp towards Izuku.

"You think way too much of yourself, nerd!", he growled. "Why the fuck would I blame myself for your shitty life choices?"

"Yeah, I suppose you're right!", Izuku threw his hands in the air in frustration, apparently done with Katsuki's constantly sour temper and need for conflict. "Okay, I did it. I took the blow for you. And I would do it again without thinking twice about it!", he said the words as if he was sure nothing could anger Katsuki more. Katsuki fumed.

"Shut the fuck up you goddamn piece of shit!", Katsuki yelled. "I don't fucking owe you anything! I didn't ask you to save me and I don't owe you for it!"

"I never said you did!", Izuku yelled back. "Despite what you think of me, I saved you because I *care* about you, not because I was looking for a reward!"

"Well, good for you, then! Because you're not getting a thank you card or a grateful kiss on the cheek", he snarled cruelly, vaguely aware that he was probably overreacting, if the way Kirishima was awkwardly staring at him was anything to go by. Despite of this knowledge, he couldn't quite bring himself to stop. He could never bring himself to stop when he got like

this. “I’m not gonna call you a hero or praise you for something you *chose* to do on your own!”

“And *I am not asking you to*!”, Izuku said each word emphatically as if he thought Katsuki was a moron and goddamn it, he was about to punch this ghost in the fucking face. “How hard is it to get into your thick head that I didn’t do what I did because of second intentions?”

“The *fuck* did you just say to me?!”, Katsuki whispered dangerously, hoarsely, the vein in his temple going back to popping out violently. “Did you just call me a *thick head*?!”

“Oh, shit”, Kirishima muttered, standing up from the bed as well as looking conflicted. His eyes darted towards the door every other two seconds, desperate to get away before things got ugly. “I’d – I’d better go”, he announced nervously, but the words fell on deaf ears.

“Look, Kacchan, I’m sorry that me trying to prevent you from dying makes you so angry”, Izuku settled for replying instead, looking upset. “I wasn’t trying to get credit for it”, he shook his head. “I wasn’t trying to prove I’m better. I was just trying to protect you. Only that!”, he exclaimed, as if begging Katsuki to understand. He had a pleading look in his eyes and in his tone of voice. Katsuki gritted his teeth.

“You goddamn piece of shit”, he growled, shaking his head and stepping closer to Deku. Kirishima looked like he didn’t know whether he should stop Katsuki from attempting to punch a ghost or just flee from the scene at once. Katsuki stood right in front of Izuku with burning, crimson eyes. “What in fuck’s name were you thinking, throwing yourself in front of a villain with an unknown quirk?!”

Kirishima and Izuku froze, staring at Katsuki with blatant confusion.

“Wha–“, Izuku tried to say, but before he could get the words out, Katsuki exploded in furious shouting.

“Because if you weren’t trying to get credit for it or shove it in my face, then that means you actually threw yourself in front of the blast without knowing what the fuck it would do to you!”, he accused, taking another angry step towards Izuku. “What the fuck is wrong with you, shitty Deku?! Did your mom drop you on your head when you were a baby?”

Izuku continued to stare at Katsuki with wide eyes, parted lips, and a dumbfounded face that showed just how he was completely taken aback by the shift in that conversation. Kirishima looked equally confused.

“Kacchan –“, he tried to say, hesitant, at the same time Kirishima said:

“Bakugou –“

“Just shut the fuck up, the two of you!”, Katsuki yelled, running his fingers through his hair while trying not to accidentally blow up his own head. “God fucking damn it, of all the people in the world I could have ended up stuck with, it had to be the dumb piece of shit with a god complex and no self-preservation skills”, he growled angrily.

“Kacchan, just calm down –“, Izuku took a tentative step towards Katsuki.

“Don’t fucking tell me what to do, you damn nerd!”, Katsuki interrupted him, pointing an accusing finger at the boy. “You can’t even fend for yourself, don’t assume you know what’s best for me!”

“Bakugou, just take a breath and sit down before Recovery Girl makes you stay here longer!”, Kirishima argued, reaching a calming hand towards his friend. Katsuki growled lowly at the back of his throat, huffing out a breath and hesitating for a moment. When Kirishima took a hold of his arm, meaning to lead him back towards the bed, Katsuki yanked himself away from his friend’s grasp like a stubborn kid, but after a few moments of ponderation he threw himself on the bed, sitting with his legs crisscrossed and his shoulders hunched as a small sign of displeasure.

Izuku blinked slowly at Katsuki, looking a bit hurt by the fact that he had listened to Kirishima and not him, but he opted to say nothing.

“You have to calm down, man. Your head’s still healing and you can’t keep shouting so much at a medical bay”, Kirishima sat back down beside Katsuki, placing a comforting hand on his shoulder. Katsuki immediately shrugged away from the touch.

“Tch. Yeah, whatever, shit hair”, Katsuki scoffed but agreed. Izuku frowned at this, looking almost offended.

“That’s what *I’ve* been telling you!”, he protested, stepping in front of Katsuki’s field of vision as if to draw his attention.

“Shut the fuck up, nerd”, Katsuki snapped at him. “You don’t get to tell me what’s best for me after you nearly got your ass killed over nothing”.

“It wasn’t over *nothing*”, Izuku’s frown deepened, stepping closer to Katsuki.

“Well, I can look after myself and I don’t need your shitty help!”, he protested, crossing his arms above his chest and giving Izuku a disapproving glare. “I was probably going to dodge anyway, so you just got ourselves into this situation over *nothing*!”

“You see? That’s why I didn’t tell you anything!”, Izuku pointed out. “You never believe anything I say, but as soon as anyone else says it, you believe them! Just ask Kirishima-kun if he thinks you were going to dodge or not, from what he saw in the footage!”, he gestured at where Kirishima was sitting, looking uncomfortable and confused.

“As if shitty hair would be able to tell”, Katsuki snorted through his nose, earning an offended frown from Kirishima.

“Wait! Are you two talking about me?”, he exclaimed, half-indignant and half-curious.

“Shut up”, Katsuki rolled his eyes, sounding a bit too defensive. He didn’t want to hear from his best friend that Deku was right, so it would be better not to ask in the first place.

“What is Midoriya saying? I want to know!”, Kirishima protested, curiosity overcoming indignation. Katsuki’s defensive tone only contributed to that feeling.

“Ask him if you were going to dodge!”, Izuku urged, taking advantage of Kirishima’s curious question.

“I already told you a hundred times that I’m not your fucking delivery boy!”, Katsuki responded, standing up from the bed again in his anger.

“Don’t you want to know?”, Izuku raised a defying eyebrow at him, the *fucking brat*. The way he spoke the words, as if he thought Katsuki was a fucking moron, as if he thought he had any right to act so smug and superior, as if he was right and Katsuki was wrong – all of that made a familiar mixture of emotions that only *Deku* could cause appear inside his chest and explode before he knew better.

“God, Deku, it’s like you’re fucking begging me to deck you every time you open your damn mouth!”, Katsuki said as he succumbed to old habits and pushed Izuku away, in the same way he had done so many times over the course of the many years they had known each other.

Except his hands didn’t run straight through Izuku’s ghost form, like he had expected them to.

His hands hit Izuku’s shoulders, shoving him away so harshly the boy fell on his butt with a yelp, looking as surprised as Katsuki was.

Katsuki had touched him.

Izuku blinked up at him from the floor, green eyes wide and mouth hanging open like a fish’s. Katsuki continued to stare at him in horror, and the look on his face sent a wave of fear through Kirishima. He had never seen such a look on Bakugou’s face before.

“What? What’s going on?”, he asked nervously from the bed, completely unaware that *Katsuki had just touched Izuku even though he was a ghost*. “Bakugou?”, he urged nervously when he received no reply, worried that something horrible had happened.

Instead of responding, Katsuki simply grabbed Kirishima by the hand, eyes never leaving Izuku’s form on the ground. He dragged Kirishima towards where Izuku was sitting, crouching down beside the fallen boy and dragging Kirishima down with him despite his confused yelps of protest. He led Kirishima’s hand towards Izuku’s shoulder, but the red-haired boy’s hand just passed straight through Deku as if he was a hologram.

“Could you feel that?”, Katsuki asked, a serious, cautious look on his face that contrasted harshly from his eruptive anger from a few moments before. It looked as if he was finally allowing logic to take over anger, assessing the situation carefully and trying to reach a conclusion as to what the heck was happening. Kirishima frowned.

“Uh, no, I didn’t feel anything”, Kirishima said simply, staring at Katsuki with worry. Katsuki let go of his friend’s hand dismissively, eyes never leaving Izuku.

“Wasn’t talking to you”, he said simply, sustaining Izuku’s terrified gaze. Crimson and green were permanently locked, unable to break away.

“N-No”, Izuku responded hesitantly. “I didn’t feel anything”.

“Bakugou?”, Kirishima asked, confused and having no clue of what was happening as he kneeled on the floor beside Katsuki.

Katsuki slowly, carefully placed his hand on the top of Izuku’s, tentative at first, as if he feared his touch would go right through the boy as Kirishima’s had, but then hesitant once he was able to feel the skin of Izuku’s knuckles beneath the tip of his fingers. He looked at the place where their skins touched with attention before meeting Izuku’s eyes again.

“And this?”, he asked again, face impassive. Izuku looked like he was trying really hard not to blush. Kacchan didn’t sound soft, but he didn’t sound as angry as before, either. He sounded careful and analytic. “Can you feel this?”

“Y-Y-Yes”, Izuku said, voice wobbly with emotion. “I can feel it! I can feel you, Kacchan!”, he exclaimed, right before he launched himself onto Katsuki, enveloping in a tight hug and burying his face on the boy’s neck as he broke into sobs. He wasn’t completely unreachable. He could still be *touched*.

All Katsuki could think of was the way he had felt Izuku’s hair tickle him when he whispered in his ear on the previous night. The way his hair was tickling him on that moment, as he hugged Katsuki, was very similar. The damn nerd needed to get himself a haircut. He had assumed the tickle from the previous night to be a mere fruit of his imagination, a stupid way his brain found to compensate the paradox of Izuku being there and not being there at the same time. He had never considered the possibility that he could *touch* Izuku and have Izuku touch him back.

Even though Katsuki’s first instinct was to shove Deku away and mock him for hugging him and crying on his shoulder, something prevented him from doing so. In fact, he didn’t even complain about the hug – he merely stayed crouched there, arms hanging limply beside him as Izuku clung to him and sobbed, overwhelmed by the emotion of the discovery he was still tangible. Katsuki knew he should probably hug Deku back, but he just… couldn’t. He didn’t understand why, but he couldn’t. Maybe he just wasn’t a hugger. Maybe there was another unfathomable reason behind it.

“Bakugou?”, Kirishima asked, still very confused and not knowing what to do, seeing the uncomfortable – and slightly embarrassed – expression that had overtaken Katsuki’s face upon being hugged by the person he considered a rival.

“I…”, he hesitated, taken aback by the course of events. Never had he expected that he would actually be able to touch Izuku. Never had he expected that he would actually be able to reach him. That Izuku was still reachable. He didn’t know what that meant. In fact, if anything, he was *afraid* of what that meant. The words died on his tongue. There was no way he could explain what was happening, the unwanted intimacy of the touch he was sharing with Izuku, without making it sound even weirder than it felt.

“I can feel you!”, Izuku exclaimed again, breaking their awkward hug but letting his hands linger on Katsuki’s arms, as if he didn’t dare to break the contact now that he knew he could make it. His face was flushed and wet with emotion, and Katsuki finally broke away from Izuku’s overwhelming gaze, turning his head.

“Yeah”, Katsuki said, face blank and eyes distant. He looked troubled. For the first time in his life, he had no clue of what to do. No clue at all. “Yeah, I can feel you, too, Deku”, he settled for saying, nowhere as angrily as he had intended – not that it really mattered.

Chapter End Notes

ohh boy

Chapter 4: Tokoyami-kun's Nightly Walk Saves the Day

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Katsuki blinked blankly at All Might, Aizawa sensei and the principal of UA sitting in front of him.

Beside him, he could spot, from the corner of his eyes, the way Deku was fiddling with the hem of his shirt, so obviously nervous that it made Katsuki want to deck him. He continued to stare at his teachers and the principal with impassive eyes as he tried to make sense of what he had just been told. Of what *they* had just been told.

“So”, Katsuki finally said after what felt like an eternity of awkward silence. His eyes squinted as he said the words, marking his disbelief and, most of all, his discomfort with that situation clear. “What you’re saying is that… Deku’s soul is…”, he trailed off, unable to finish the sentence. All Might looked slightly embarrassed and almost sorry for him, so it was Aizawa sensei who responded, as serious as ever.

“Bound to yours”, he concluded, crossing his arms above his chest. Deku emitted a sound that was suspiciously like a muffled yelp from beside him, but Katsuki knew better than to even acknowledge it. “This is all theoretical, however. We won’t know for sure how this quirk works until we actually capture the villain who did this”, he shrugged. As if the subject they were discussing wasn’t a big deal. As if Deku’s soul being literally *bound* to Katsuki’s was just occupational hazard.

“And how close are we to capturing him?”, Deku asked anxiously, leaning slightly forwards in anticipation, at the same time Katsuki asked:

“But what the fuck is that supposed to mean, *bound*?”

Aizawa sensei, having only heard Katsuki’s question, sighed heavily and leaned back on his chair, looking like he wasn’t in the mood for dealing with his student’s moody attitude. This time, All Might was the one who answered him, looking like he was trying his best not to make Katsuki freak out because of the information he was about to hear. The fact that he was even trying only made Katsuki’s desire to blow up the entire room increase.

“From what we could gather from your testimony, the surveillance images of the alley, and quirk records, the villain’s blow detached young Midoriya’s soul from his body, as you know”, he started. “We found past quirks that behaved in a similar way, so that is not impossible. However, since you can see and interact with young Midoriya when none of us can, we reached the conclusion that your souls must have been connected to each other in a way. It was probably not the villain’s intention to do so, but given that he opted to run away instead of killing you off while you were both unconscious, we can only assume that something must have gone wrong. We also have records of soul-binding quirks, but they are extremely rare and…”, he trailed off again, lowering his head slightly. Katsuki definitely didn’t like the look of that, or the path that conversation seemed to be taking.

“And *what*?”, he urged, a bit too aggressively, especially given the fact that he was talking not only to a teacher, but to *All Might*.

“The aftermath is often…”, Aizawa sensei spoke up instead, staring deeply into Katsuki’s eyes. “Unpleasant”.

“U-Unpleasant?”, Deku muttered hesitantly from beside Katsuki.

“The hell is that supposed to mean?”, Katsuki growled, even though he was also feeling… weird. He couldn’t quite describe the sensation, but there was something cold weighting down on the pit of his stomach.

“We don’t want to rush into conclusions”, Principal Nezu interrupted, sounding as calm and gentle as ever, which contrasted with All Might’s grim expression and Aizawa sensei’s sulking look. “All quirks are different and none behaves the same. We shouldn’t measure our chances at success based on previous attempts when it comes to this type of situation, especially when there are such singular differences amongst quirks. For now, you must focus on catching up with the two days’ worth of classes you lost. We will update you on the progress of our searches for the villain and inform you should anything change”, he offered Katsuki a small smile, which the boy certainly didn’t repay.

“But you said soul-binding quirks are rare”, Katsuki said, ignoring Principal Nezu’s obvious dismissal. “Which means you couldn’t have found many occurrences. This can only mean –“

“*As* – the Principal has said”, Aizawa sensei cut Katsuki short, giving him a warning glare. His teachers may have already gotten used to his disrespectful behavior, even if they didn’t condone it, but talking back to – or even worse, *ignoring* – the Principal of UA was not something Katsuki would be able to get away with, concussed or not. “You should focus on making up for the lost time. We are more than competent to track this villain down and restore Midoriya’s soul to his body on our own, Bakugou”, he added, as if predicting that Katsuki would want to take part into the investigations.

“Yeah, but how can I concentrate on studying and making up for the lost time when I have a mumbling nerd glued to me 24/7?”, Katsuki complained, sparing the still nervous Deku beside him one quick disapproving glance. He turned back to Aizawa sensei before Deku could protest. “I’d be more useful helping you track this villain down. We all know I’m on top of my class, so missing a few days won’t affect shit for me. Plus, I’ve faced this guy before”, he pointed out, hopeful. He didn’t think he’d be able to just sit down and wait until someone captured the villain for him, especially when he had shitty Deku glued to him like a flea. More than that, even – Katsuki couldn’t stand the thought that a stupid villain like that had almost taken him down, and that someone else would get to do the honors of capturing him. He convinced himself that this wasn’t just a matter of getting rid of Deku – this was a matter of defending his honor, too.

“Young Bakugou, you are still injured”, All Might pointed out calmly, protesting Katsuki’s demand as he had expected to, so, before he could continue, Katsuki interrupted him.

“Recovery Girl said I’m getting cleared out –“

“*Soon*”, Aizawa sensei cut him short again, pointing Katsuki with a slightly more irritated glare. Principal Nezu watched the exchange with his same usual peaceful expression, but something about his eyes made Katsuki feel uneasy. “Not now. Recovery Girl said you would be dismissed *soon*. And we need to work on capturing this villain immediately, or as soon as possible”, he sighed. “Besides, we wouldn’t allow a first-year student to take part on such a dangerous mission, especially when another student’s life is on the line”, he concluded, his tone leaving no space for refutation.

Katsuki squinted his eyes, suspicion mixing with the cold feeling on his stomach. There was something else going on – something they weren’t telling him. Of course, it wasn’t exactly best-case scenario to have one of UA’s students lying brain-dead in a hospital bed after a villain attack during a training session, but Katsuki could see no reason behind Aizawa’s sensei and Principal Nezu’s desperate rush to find the villain and shove Deku’s soul back into his body. Katsuki could understand All Might’s urge to do so, now that he knew about the man’s weird relationship with the nerd, but the two other’s… There was something off about it. Katsuki was sure they couldn’t be in a rush because they took pity on him being stuck with Deku for longer than necessary. There was something else behind it, especially because Aizawa sensei said Deku’s life was on the line. The hell was that supposed to mean? As far as Katsuki knew, Deku’s soul had been set lose, yeah, but he wasn’t under any imminent risk of dying for real. Was he?

… Was he?

“What the hell is that supposed to mean?”, he asked, making sure Aizawa sensei could read the suspicion etched in his crimson eyes. None of the three men replied, so he continued. “Why immediately? The fuck do you mean Deku’s life is on the line?”

“Shouta”, Principal Nezu said simply, a hidden warning in his tone.

“It is better for them to know –“, Aizawa sensei tried to protest with a sigh, but Principal Nezu stood up, calmly making his way around the table separating him from Katsuki and standing in front of the boy, right beside Deku. Katsuki stared at the small Principal with respect, but didn’t allow his glare to falter.

“Young Bakugou”, Principal Nezu said, voice calm. “You should return to the medical bay. You still need to rest if you plan on recovering and returning to your classes as soon as possible. We will inform you should you be needed, or should any news regarding the villain arise”.

“Yeah, ok, but what should me and Deku know?”, Katsuki turned to look at Aizawa sensei, who had a very serious expression on his face. Now that Principal Nezu had stopped his teacher from saying what he wanted, Katsuki could clearly see that Aizawa sensei had been subtly dropping hints from him to catch on, almost as if he wanted to help Katsuki figure things out on his own. The man turned his head away from him, but Katsuki wasn’t letting the subject drop that easily. “Sensei?”, he urged.

“Young Bakugou”, it was All Might who responded, standing up from his seat and walking towards him, just as Principal Nezu had. “Listen to the Principal. Go back to the medical bay and rest. We can talk about this once you are fully recovered”.

Katsuki glared at the superhero with the fury of a thousand suns, mixed emotions filling his chest. He was desperate to know what the precise hell these people meant by saying Deku's life was on the line. He wanted to figure out what having the shitty nerd attached to his soul like a flea meant. He needed to know why they were keeping secrets, why Aizawa sensei was trying to drop hints for him, why Principal Nezu seemed so adamant at getting rid of him before he could learn too much.

But, at the same time, there was a silent pleading in All Might's eyes, a silent warning in Aizawa sensei's, and an unreadable look in Principal Nezu's. As much as Katsuki hated it, his only course of action was to fall back. Even though he was stubborn and hot-heated, he knew better than to go against the Principal of the UA, who could expel his ass in the blink of an eye if he wanted to.

"Fine", he huffed out a grumpy, disrespectful breath, standing up from his seat and shoving his hands into his pockets in annoyance. There was a constant grimace on his face, but that was nothing new.

"Don't worry, Young Bakugou", All Might said, passing an arm around Katsuki's shoulder and tapping it paternally. Katsuki told himself that he was definitely not freaking out inside for having All Might half-hug him like that. "We will not keep you in the dark. We just ask that you rest and get your strength back, while trusting us to deal with the fight this time".

"Heh. Whatever", he scoffed, forcing himself to shrug All Might's protective arm off before he could actually feel embarrassed by it. Pointedly not looking at Deku, Katsuki turned his back on the three men in the room and, without bidding his goodbyes or being formally excused, walked out of Principal Nezu's office without glancing back. None of his teachers scolded him for it.

He didn't need to turn and look to know Deku was tagging along – it wasn't like the nerd had any other choice. However, even without looking, he could just tell that Deku was probably freaking out over all the information they had received in the past few minutes. Their souls were *bounded*, and there seemed to be a death clock looming over Deku's head. Katsuki could almost hear the whirring of wheels inside Deku's brain, if the way he kept muttering under his breath was anything to go by.

"What the fuck did I tell you about muttering, you damn nerd?", Katsuki asked after a while, without looking at Deku, continuing his calm walk towards Recovery Girl's medbay. The boy's muttering, along with his constant crying, had always pissed the hell out of Katsuki, and he was sure he would probably descend into actual madness if he was forced to hear it 24/7. Dealing with the shitty nerd being glued to him 24/7 was already too much.

If Katsuki was being honest, he wasn't particularly looking forward to returning to the heroine's white rooms and wrinkled kisses – if there was something he wanted to do was to lie down on his own bed, of his own UA room, in the peace and quiet of his private space. Alone. No annoying Deku around, no annoying parents, no annoying teachers, no annoying friends, no annoying villains. He'd only been glued – he refused to use the word *bound* – to Deku for a couple of days, and he was already desperate for space.

Deku, however, was either too busy with his ponderations to hear Katsuki's scolding or downright ignored him, which only made the explosive boy's anger increase. He stopped on his tracks in the middle of the corridor, so abruptly that Deku, distracted, bumped into him with a surprised yelp (Katsuki decided not to dwell on the fact that touching Deku felt especially weird now, not because of the touching itself but because he was the *only one* who currently could). Taken away from his own loud thoughts and looking up at Katsuki with wide, green eyes, Deku stared up at him with confusion, as if trying to figure out why they had suddenly stopped.

And fuck, now that Deku's eyes had locked with his, Katsuki couldn't look away. He didn't know why, but he couldn't look away.

"Kacchan", Deku frowned slightly after several awkward, silent seconds passed and Katsuki did nothing other than stare at him with what looked like a death glare. "Is everything all right?"

Kacchan!

The huge, expressive eyes assumed a worried glance and Katsuki couldn't take it anymore. There was something unsettling about those eyes, but he couldn't – for the life of him, he couldn't – he couldn't – remember – …

Dead.

Deku's eyes had been dead.

The memory came to him as if in a flash, a spark, something that was sudden and abrupt and that was gone as quickly as it started. He didn't know what caused the flashback or if it would have even happened had he not stared into Deku's eyes for so long, but now all he could see were half-lidded, dead eyes that were vacant, expressionless, empty, dead, dead, dead, *dead*. He didn't know why it upset him so much. He couldn't understand. He didn't understand. He'd fantasized about killing Deku so many times – why did the sight upset him so much, now?

What had changed?

"Kacchan!", Deku exclaimed, his worry increasing a tenfold as he noticed the way Katsuki's eyes widened and his face paled as if he had seen a ghost. His gaze was distant, as if he was stuck in a memory, but the way his breathing pattern suddenly increased showed that there was something making him distressed. Instinctively, Deku reached towards the boy in front of him, grabbing one of his arms in a desperate attempt to help him. "Kacchan! What's wrong?!"

Touching Katsuki – or rather, squeezing one of his arms – seemed to be what it took to break him from his trance, and in a moment, his eyes had regained their sharpness and focus. Staring deeply into Deku's eyes for what felt like an eternity, Katsuki yanked his arm away from Deku's loosening grip and scoffed at him, pointing him with a disgusted, disapproving look that didn't feel entirely wholehearted, neither to Katsuki nor to Izuku.

“Don’t touch me, scum”, he growled in his usual tone, staring at Deku for a few more seconds as if he wanted to be sure of something before turning on his heels and resuming his walk. “And stop fucking muttering. It’s driving me crazy”, he added over his shoulder, not really bothering to look directly at Deku as he spoke. He shoved his hands into his pockets again and hunched over, resuming his walk back to his room at the medical bay. Izuku stared at Katsuki for a few confused seconds before following him, as he had done all his life. Apparently, some things never changed.

If Katsuki hadn’t been able to take his eyes off Izuku a few moments before, now he seemed to be avoiding him like the plague. The two boys walked side by side towards the medical bay in a trek that felt longer than ever, the tense silence between them weighting heavy on their shoulders. Izuku had no idea what had upset Kacchan so much or why he had reacted in such way – it was usual for him to be aggressive to Izuku, especially when he touched him, but there was something different about his reaction his time. If Izuku didn’t know better – if Izuku hadn’t known Kacchan for his entire life – he would have described him almost as…

Almost as *scared*.

If anything, the thought of *Kacchan*, of all people, feeling scared, made Izuku pretty scared, too.

Lowering his head and fiddling with the hem of his shirt awkwardly, Izuku struggled to keep up with Kacchan’s quick pace. Seeing the brave, relentless boy look so disturbed by something he couldn’t name made anxiety creep up inside of him, and the need to mutter his thoughts aloud became almost irresistible. There were just *so many thoughts* in his head. He knew better than to do that, though.

Izuku knew Katsuki didn’t like him. The thought hurt him like hell – he learned how to deal with this feeling after he made friends for the first time in his life at the UA, but to know that Kacchan, his childhood best friend, his parameter for victory, hated him, still stung after all those years of bullying and violence. Izuku couldn’t help but to admire Kacchan, despite of everything that had happened between them. He only wished the feeling was requited.

But the fact was Kacchan hated him, no matter what Izuku’s wishes were, and being stuck with him, of all people, was probably a nightmare for the explosive boy. As much as Izuku wished Kacchan would at least tolerate and respect him, he didn’t want to impose himself onto the boy like that. And, despite of it not being his fault, imposing his presence onto Kacchan was precisely what he was doing. The least he could do was to respect the boy’s wishes and not mutter, since Kacchan despised it so much.

But still. So. Many. Thoughts. He needed to let them all out in some way.

“W-What do you think Aizawa sensei meant?”, Izuku asked hesitantly, already panting from having to walk so fast in order to keep up with Kacchan. “When he said a student’s life was on the line?”

Instead of responding, Katsuki simply scoffed, avoiding to look at Izuku’s general direction. Izuku stared at him for a few moments, hoping that the boy would answer his question, but Katsuki simply continued to walk. They entered Recovery Girl’s med bay, and headed

towards the elevator. Izuku tried to press the button to call for it out of habit, frustration filling him when his hand phased right through the wall. Katsuki couldn't help but to roll his eyes at the sight, pressing the button himself and waiting for the doors to open.

"I – I didn't think I was in danger of – of actually… you know", Izuku shrugged, giving another go at making conversation with Kacchan. The boy continued to stare straight ahead in silence, hands shoved in his pockets and face grim with annoyance. "Sure, it's horrible that I'm stuck out of my body, but – I thought we just needed to capture the villain. I didn't think that I'd –", he trailed off again, lips sealing shut. He realized with a twist in his chest that he never even considered the possibility that he was under risk of dying. It was obvious, now that he thought about it – his soul was literally disconnected from his body. That's as close to dying a person can get without actually kicking the bucket, right?

But now, as the threat of actually losing his life, of ceasing to exist, of… drifting off. It was real. It was very real. And it made dread appear at the bottom of his stomach.

He didn't want to die. He was All Might's successor. He was meant to be the new symbol of peace, now that All Might couldn't be anymore. He didn't want to disappoint his mentor. He didn't want to go without at least passing One For All for the next successor. He didn't want to leave his mom.

Oh, god, his *mom*. What would she do if he died like that? Who would take care of her? Who would comfort her? How could he leave her? And All Might, and his legacy; how could he go without ensuring it would live on? How could he be such a disappointment –

"Quit the bullshit", Kacchan broke him off his thoughts, speaking for the first time since he abruptly yanked himself away from Izuku's touch. He still wasn't looking at him, and when the elevator pinged open in front of them, he stepped in unceremoniously, Izuku following him close. He was watching Kacchan like a hawk, confused and afraid, but it took him a few silent moments before he continued speaking. "I'm not gonna give you a hug, or pat your back, or tell you everything will be ok. I'm not one of your shitty melodramatic friends. If you're looking for comfort, go bug someone else off".

Izuku frowned. That – that wasn't what he was trying to achieve. He was just voicing his thoughts. Had his sudden fear of dying been that obvious?

"S-Sorry", he ended up saying, even though he wasn't entirely sure what he was sorry about. "That wasn't – it wasn't what I meant".

"I don't care what the fuck you meant, just quit being such a cry baby over everything for once in your damn life", Kacchan growled, tilting his head away from Izuku. A long silence stretched between them – Izuku had no idea what he could say without giving the wrong impression. The elevator door opened, and they both stepped out. They were nearing Kacchan's bedroom.

They entered it silently, Kacchan holding the door for Izuku in order to close it after him, since the boy wouldn't be able to do it himself – his hand would phase right through it. Once the door was closed and whatever little privacy Katsuki could maintain was preserved, he

kicked his shoes off and threw himself on the bed. His head didn't hurt as much, thankfully, and he sighed in relief.

Izuku lingered awkwardly in the middle of the bedroom, not knowing what to do with himself. Even though he was a ghost, sleeping on the floor was making his back grow achy and his shoulders become sore, but he couldn't tell Kacchan that. He would just be accused of being a cry baby again. So he simply sat on the floor beside Kacchan's bed as he had been doing for the past days, crossing his legs beneath him and trying to decipher what Aizawa sensei had meant by everything he had said during their meeting.

He hadn't expected Kacchan to speak up again.

"You're not dying, Deku", he said quietly, calmly. There was something weird about his tone of voice and, if Izuku bothered to turn his head around, he would have been able to see Kacchan's face. He didn't do that, however. It didn't feel right. Instead, he simply sat on the floor and stared straight ahead. "So quit dwelling over it. They're probably just trying to get your shitty ghost back into your body as soon as possible before the media blasts their asses. They're not the only ones looking forward to do that".

Izuku gave off a tiny chuckle at the comment. It was so like Kacchan to say something like that.

"Y-Yeah", Izuku agreed. "You're probably right", he admitted, even though he knew that Kacchan probably *wasn't*, despite of everything.

"I *know* I'm fucking right", Kacchan scoffed, shifting on the bed. Izuku heard the sound of covers being pulled as Kacchan nestled himself to sleep.

"You're going to sleep again, Kacchan?", he asked, doing his best to keep the worry off his tone. He knew Kacchan needed to rest, but he also knew he had been sleeping too much. It made him worried.

"None of your business, you damn nerd", Kacchan responded simply with his usual growl. "Just stop overthinking about the meeting and keep your nose off what I do. I'm not letting you die, so just chill out".

Izuku's eyes widened slightly. Had he heard it right?

He continued so stare straight ahead at the floor, a blush creeping up to his cheeks. He couldn't look at Kacchan. The silence between them was verging on unbearable.

"Don't think too much of yourself", Kacchan scoffed after what felt like an eternity, sounding a bit too defensive. "There's no way I can beat your shitty nerd ass if you're dead, so I'm not letting that happen. You don't get to take the easy way out against me, dumbass".

Izuku smiled, even though his face was red. Yeah, that made more sense.

"Don't worry, Kacchan. I can't surpass you if I'm dead either, so that's not happening", he said simply, almost teasing, hugging his knees to his chest. He was used to the lack of

physical contact – he spent most of his life without friends, and the only person who ever hugged him was his mom. He knew how to do without touching. But still, back then – he was *able* to touch people if he wanted to. Now, the only one he could touch was Kacchan, and Kacchan – well.

Angry with Izuku's comment but too tired to blast his nerdy ass into the afterlife, Katsuki simply launched one pillow at the boy. It phased right through Izuku and plopped uselessly at the floor, neither of the boys making any sort of effort to pick it back up.

Katsuki was cleared out of the infirmary on the following day, receiving advice from Recovery Girl not to exert himself for at least a week and return to her if he felt anything out of the ordinary. Apparently, the hit he had taken to the head – thanks to Deku launching himself at Full Cowl towards him – had been really serious and, if it hadn't been for Recovery Girl's powers, he would have probably been in a coma. He wanted to scream. Hah. Him, getting in a fucking coma because of shitty Deku. What a fucking joke.

It would have been a fucking joke, had he heard it a year back. Now, Katsuki knew full well that Deku had enough power to yank his spine off his body using only one hand, if he wanted to. He would never admit it out loud, but that didn't change the fact that he *knew it*.

Since Recovery Girl cleared him out in the nighttime, Katsuki decided he could stall for time for a bit instead of heading straight to the students' dormitory. He didn't want to have to deal with shitty hair and dumb Pikachu spamming him with questions he didn't want to answer, or with the attention he was sure he'd receive. He didn't think he would have a better mood to deal with it in the morning, but at least he'd be more well-rested. He was sure a good night of sleep in his own bed was bound to make him feel better. Despite of looking comfortable, the medical bay's bed was killing his back. It felt constantly achy and sore, as if he had been sleeping on the floor, instead of a mattress.

Deku followed Katsuki around quietly as he paced through the UA grounds, hoping no one would find him and tell him to go to the dormitory. All he wanted was a few moments of peace, of quiet, or privacy – or, at least, as much privacy as he could get with Deku attached to him like a flea. God, it was pissing him off so much. He tried not to think about it, and even though Deku was at least respectful enough to stay quiet while he walked around, Katsuki still couldn't ignore green hair and lively eyes whenever he turned his head to the side.

It was almost midnight when Deku finally spoke up, having miraculously broken the record and managing to stay silent for almost two hours straight.

“Kacchan”, he said quietly, almost as if not to startle Katsuki. He sounded hesitant. “Aren’t you feeling tired?”

“Hah”, Katsuki scoffed, a mocking grin appearing on his face. “Walking around for two little hours makes you exhausted, nerd?”, he teased. Deku blushed and looked defensive all of a sudden.

“What? No!”, he protested. “It’s just you’ve been really tired lately, and sleeping a lot, so I figured you would want to head straight to bed once you were cleared out of the medical bay”, he justified, frowning. Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“Yeah, but you forgot to take your shitty friends into account”, he explained. “I’m not really in the mood of dealing with a bunch of people hovering all around me and asking me stupid questions”.

The answer Deku gave him was certainly not what he had been expecting.

“T-They’re… They’re your friends, too, Kacchan”, he said, frown deepening, sounding almost pitying. Rage boiled inside of Katsuki, and he turned his head to glare at Deku with a disgusted scowl appearing on his lips.

“God, you’re pathetic”, he accused. “Get the hell away from me with this sentimental bullshit”.

“But they are!”, Deku protested, following Katsuki when he turned on his heels and marched away. “Really, I mean it. I’m sure they must be worried about you, and if they ask you questions, it’s because they care! That’s a good thing!”

“I don’t know what the fuck you’re talking about”, he scoffed. He couldn’t tell why, but Deku’s words were making him angrier than usual. “But there’s nothing *good* about having a bunch of assholes cornering me and pissing me off, so shut the hell up”.

“I really don’t get you sometimes, Kacchan”, Deku pushed, walking alongside the boy and looking serious. “Why are you so afraid –“

He was cut off by Katsuki stopping abruptly and turning on his heels, one of his hands shoving Deku back with such harshness that the boy lost balance and fell on his butt with a yelp. Katsuki stood in front of him, staring down at his surprised form with a murderous glare and balled-up fists.

“I thought I told you to mind your own fucking business”, he hissed, fury so evident in his voice that Deku’s eyes widened. “I’m not *afraid* of any fucking thing, so just shut the fuck up and keep your stupid advice for your damn self. If you were so good at making friends, you wouldn’t have spent most of your life as a friendless loser”, he spat, accusing. The moment when Deku’s eyes turned from shocked to hurt was almost tangible, and Katsuki convinced himself that the twinging feeling inside his chest was disgust, and not guilt, at the expression that took over the fallen boy’s face.

“That was unnecessary, Kacchan”, Deku’s breath was shaky and heavy, as if he was fighting back tears. He leaned his hands on the grassy floor and got back to his feet, standing up in an awkward position. A spike of pain went up Katsuki’s spine, making him bite back a hiss. If this weird ass pain didn’t disappear after he slept on his proper bed, he would be forced to talk to Recovery Girl.

“Yeah?”, Katsuki raised one eyebrow, ignoring the pain and closing the space between himself and Deku. Deku didn’t flinch back as he usually would, which unsettled Katsuki. After they entered UA, Deku seemed to lose his fear of him – if anything, the little shit grew braver and braver every day. This drove Katsuki *crazy*. The need to put Deku back into his place was more overwhelming than ever. “I think it was necessary as *fuck*. Because you seem to be under the impression that we’re friends now, just because I can’t get rid of you, even though I have told you time and time again we’re *anything but*. So it’s about time you wake the hell up to reality and stop pretending you care just because you want me to pretend I care in return. I told you I ain’t gonna comfort you, I ain’t gonna braid your hair and I ain’t gonna give you a get-well-soon hug, so stop trying so hard, you desperate piece of shit”, he spat venomously.

His heart hurt, his head hurt, his back hurt, and he felt more tired than ever. Suddenly, his pleasant walk across the empty grounds of the UA didn’t seem so pleasant anymore, and even going back to the dormitory to face his horribly loud, nosy friends seemed like a better option than having this conversation with Deku. Leave it to *fucking Deku* to ruin one of his favorite habits, god *damn* it. He hated him so much, his heart felt like it was breaking.

Fuck, now that he thought about it, his heart really *did* feel like it was breaking. What the fuck was that about?

Deku was hiding his face behind the crook of his arm as if he didn’t want Katsuki to see him crying, so Katsuki complied to his wish. A lifetime of seeing Deku cry was already enough, and he turned on his heels to march to the opposite direction from where he had been heading. Heading towards the dormitory, it didn’t take Katsuki too long to hear the sound of Deku following him, clearly not due to his own will. However, to his surprise, he was soon stopped on his tracks as an unseen force pushed him back the way he came, so abruptly he lost balance. Looking back, he found Deku standing up and staring at him with a shocked look.

Had he just – ?

“If we’re soulbound, then it must work both ways”, he said with curiosity, cleaning his running nose with the back of his hand and sniffing. Deku’s face was damp with tears, but he looked hurt and determined at the same time. Katsuki got back to his feet, ignoring the pain on his back and glaring daggers at the boy in front of him. “I’m not going anywhere, Kacchan”, Deku had the audacity to announce. He sounded familiarly relentless.

“We’ll see about that, you damn nerd”, Katsuki growled in an animalistic way before taking several steps back as abruptly as he could, rejoicing in the way Deku was forced forwards, in his direction. Before he could continue, however, Deku planted the heels of his feet on the floor and brought Katsuki to another abrupt stop.

“If I have to follow you around, then you’ll have to follow me around, too”, Deku announced stubbornly, making Katsuki’s blood boil. “We need to talk about this, for once".

“You’re the one who’s supposed to follow me around, asshole!”, Katsuki spat, taking another abrupt step away and dragging Deku with him again in the process. Deku, in his turn, took a step to the opposite direction, dragging Katsuki with him by their invisible bond. It was like a stupid game of tug-of-war, except the rope was invisible and they were both aggressively desperate to win. “Quit doing that!”, Katsuki protested, furious. “I’ll fuck you up if you do it again!”

“Just tell me one thing, then!”, Deku said seriously, eyes unrelenting. The green glistened in the darkness of the night, and Katsuki did his best to ignore the weird feeling that appeared at the pit of his stomach at the sight. “One thing, then I’ll stop resisting”.

“You’re not in the position to bargain with me, you dumbfuck!”, Katsuki snarled, trying to walk away again. Deku prevented him from doing so, which infuriated him even more.

“I just want to know why you think that of me”, Deku said, ignoring Katsuki’s response. The boy sounded tired, all of a sudden. As if he was done being mistreated by Katsuki for no reason – and he sure as fuck had taken his time getting fed up. “Why you always think the worse about me”, he added, tilting his head slightly to the side. Katsuki could tell that Deku was being serious about this whole “let’s talk our feelings out without punching each other for once” thing, but unfortunately to all parts involved, he was having none of it.

“I think the worse because you’re the *worst*!”, Katsuki accused, managing to take several steps and drag Deku behind him before Deku halted him and dragged him back.

“I’m serious, Kacchan!”, Deku shouted, suddenly impatient. “You always think I’m trying to use you! You always accuse me of thinking I’m better than you, or of thinking things that are not true. You just said I was pretending to care about you! I *know* you know that’s not true!”

“You don’t know *anything*, damn Deku”, Katsuki growled, furious, struggling to get the hell away from Deku and failing miserably. His hands were starting to pop with tiny explosions as he failed to control his increasing rage, the sweet smell of nitroglycerin filling the night air.

“Yes, I do”, Deku talked back to him. God, Katsuki missed the time when Deku was afraid of him and actually respected him enough to keep his *damn mouth shut*. “You *have* to know that’s not true. Kacchan”, he shook his head, voice more honest than Katsuki had ever heard it. “I gave my life for yours. Do you really think I did that because I was pretending to care? Or because I wanted recognition? Or because of *any* of the other reasons you came up with?”

“Shut up!”, Katsuki growled, not liking the turn this conversation was taking. He didn’t want to talk about any of it – his meaningless antagonism towards Deku, his bullying, his abuse, his shitty way of dealing with the stuff he was never taught how to handle, and the way it all resulted on Deku sacrificing his own life for his sake anyway. Did the stupid brat have no self-preservation whatsoever? Why the fuck would he throw his life on the line for someone who called him useless and beat him up?

What upset Katsuki so much was that, even back when he was quirkless, Deku was already a nobler hero than he would ever manage to be. And that *infuriated* him to no end.

“It was because I care about you, and I didn’t want you to die”, Deku continued, staring deep into Katsuki's eyes. He took a step closer to Katsuki, meaning to close the distance between them. There was a pleading look in his green, *alive* eyes, as if he was silently begging Katsuki to understand. “Is that really so hard to believe?”, he added quietly.

“*Yes*”, Katsuki scoffed without missing a beat, without pretending he was even considering attending to Deku’s request, angry, raw, and sincere. He didn’t want to have this conversation, but now that Deku had probed at his open wound, he might as well address the subject – the dreaded subject that had been pissing him off for years now, and that had taken him a long, long time to come to terms with. “Yes, it fucking *is* hard to believe”, he emphasized, hating the way his words sounded self-deprecating.

“Why?”, Deku asked, sounding desperate to understand. *Why is it so hard for you to believe that I care about you when all you’ve done your entire life was bully me and treat me like shit,* right? God, Deku had to be fucking kidding him. He took another step closer to Katsuki, but Katsuki didn’t take a step back. “I don’t understand, Kacchan. I respect you and admire you. I – I understand if you don’t respect me or admire me. I never asked you to. I – I haven’t earned it yet, not really. But that is still a long way away from thinking – from thinking those things you think of me. I don’t understand why you think I would be – using you or – or this other stuff you say sometimes. I don’t understand why you close yourself off from your friends. I – I just –“

“Bakugou?”, a new voice cut Izuku off before he could finish his question. Both Izuku’s and Katsuki’s heads immediately snapped towards the sound, only to find Tokoyami standing several feet away from them in the darkness of the street. The realization that he could only see Katsuki, not Izuku, and that, to him, it probably looked like Bakugou was struggling and arguing with thin air, made everyone involved feel incredibly embarrassed.

“What the fuck are you doing out here, bird-brain?”, Katsuki scowled in annoyance, trying to hide his embarrassment behind anger (as usual). Tokoyami seemed unaffected by the boy’s harsh words, continuing to stare at him with his usual neutral expression.

“I could ask you the same”, Tokoyami said simply. “Shouldn’t you be at the medical bay?”

“I got cleared out tonight”, Katsuki scoffed. “Not that it’s any of your business”.

Izuku sighed heavily and lowered his head, shaking it slightly in disapproval.

“See, this is *exactly* what I was talking about –“

“God, just *shut the fuck up*”, Katsuki groaned, closing his eyes for the briefest of seconds before he could lose his cool for good. He ignored the pop-pop-pop his hands were emitting despite of his best efforts.

“I didn’t say anything”, Tokoyami raised an eyebrow, assuming Katsuki’s scolding had been directed towards him.

“Not you”, Katsuki sighed. He was so fucking tired of having to explain who he was talking to all the time just because shitty Deku had gone and made himself invisible to everyone else.

“Oh”, Tokoyami said simply, staring blankly at the direction he assumed Izuku was standing. “I see”, he added simply. Comprehensively. “Well, why didn’t you head back to the dormitory once you got cleared out? Our friends are worried about you”.

Deku pointed Katsuki with a look that said “see? I told you they cared” at the same time Katsuki pointed Deku with a look that said “see? I told you they would all ask too many fucking questions as soon as they laid eyes on me”.

“I didn’t go back because I didn’t fucking feel like it”, Katsuki walked towards Tokoyami, Deku being dragged abruptly behind him by an invisible cord. Since their discussion had been interrupted by Tokoyami, it made no sense for Izuku to keep struggling against the force that drew him to Kacchan, so he allowed himself to be dragged along by the explosive boy. Katsuki's words were unnecessarily harsh and impolite, but that was nothing new. “Does that answer your question?”

“I can see having your skull cracked did nothing to change your sour mood", Tokoyami commented absentmindedly, walking alongside Katsuki (and, by default, Deku) as the explosive boy caught up with him. They reentered the main road that led back towards the dormitory together. “Still, I’m glad to see you back on your feet”.

“Yeah, yeah, whatever, Pidgeotto”, Katsuki scoffed, shoving his hands into his pockets. Deku pointed him with a disapproving look which had so much judgement in it that Katsuki couldn’t simply ignore. “*What*?”, he asked, head snapping towards Deku. “You want me to give bird-brain a hug too just because he’s nosy?”, he snarled. Tokoyami watched the interaction with nothing other than silent interest, eyes widening a little in surprise as he watched Katsuki address… nothing.

“He was being nice to you”, Deku pointed out as if it was obvious. “It wouldn’t hurt to be nice back”.

“Yes, it would”, Katsuki rolled his eyes as he kept on walking alongside Tokoyami, talking about him as if he wasn’t even there.

“No, Kacchan, it wouldn’t!”, Deku exclaimed with a chuckle, as if Katsuki’s lack of proper manners was extremely endearing to him. “Why don’t you just try it?”, he raised one eyebrow, as if he was suggesting something as simple as changing clothes. As if Katsuki was actually capable of doing that.

The fact that Deku was able to do something as simple as *being nice* so naturally, as if it was second nature to him, while Katsuki struggled to even say “thank you” made him want to blow a hole on the concrete beneath his feet.

“Who the fuck do you think you are? Just shut the hell up and remember your place", Katsuki growled, turning his head towards Deku and speaking in a low voice as if he didn’t want Tokoyami to hear him – or see him talking to a ghost. Probably reading the silent warning in Katsuki's crimson eyes, Deku opened and closed his mouth as if he still wanted to say

something, but ended up sealing his lips with a frustrated look – which seemed almost disappointed.

“So”, Tokoyami said after a few moments of awkward, silent walking. “How's Midoriya holding up?”

Katsuki rolled his eyes so hard he almost managed to see his own brain. He couldn’t really blame Tokoyami for asking about Deku’s well-being, instead of his – for all bird-brain knew, all he’d get in response was another bitter remark if he as much as dared to ask about how Katsuki was doing. Little did he know that, when it came to Katsuki, getting a bitter remark as a response was the only possible outcome.

“Tch. From the way he keeps blabbing in my ear, you would never guess this asshole is in a coma”, Katsuki scoffed, shrugging. Tokoyami nodded and hummed low in his throat, going back to being silent. Deku lowered his head slightly beside him as they walked, but didn’t say anything.

They were nearing the dormitory now and, even from the ground floor, the three boys could see that some of the lights were still on, ergo, some of their friends were still up. Katsuki sighed, bracing himself. Maybe if he offered one quick, rude enough response, they would leave him alone for the night. It was just a matter of scaring them into giving him personal space.

Tokoyami had his eyes glued on Katsuki, full of attention, and before the latter could burst through the door unceremoniously like he always did, he reached out and grabbed one of Katsuki's arms. Snapping his head towards Tokoyami with an indignant look, which contrasted with Deku's surprised one, Katsuki didn’t remove his arm from Tokoyami's grasp as he normally would. Instead, he simply stared, waiting for an explanation that justified that unusual touch.

“I could distract them”, Tokoyami explained quietly, the look on his face unreadable. “So you won’t have to deal with them tonight”.

“*Eh*?”, Katsuki frowned, confused by Tokoyami's unprecedented display of kindness towards him. “Why the hell would you do that for?”

“You just look like you could use the rest”, Tokoyami shrugged. “Or like you will blow up half of the dormitory if someone as much as looks at your general direction”.

Those were fair reasons, if he was being honest. He could definitely use the rest (not that he would ever admit it), and he wouldn’t underestimate the possibility that he would end up blowing the dormitory up if he had to deal with obnoxious questions about *Deku*. He studied Tokoyami's face for a few moments, suspicion embedded in his eyes, before nodding slowly. Tokoyami let go of his arm and Katsuki lowered it, allowing bird-brain to take the lead and open the door in his place. Katsuki wasn’t one to allow other people to hold the door for him, but given the fact that his other option was to face a hundred questions about *Deku, Deku this, Deku that*, he permitted himself this one exception. Tokoyami walked in just as Katsuki managed to spot the backs of Mina's, Kaminari's and Jirou's heads. He announced something loudly, something about seeing some weird animal on the streets during his midnight walk,

and the attention this raised was enough to make the three people rile up and start discussing the fictitious event as if there was no tomorrow. Katsuki took advantage of the fact that they were completely focused on Tokoyami to sneak in and rush to the stairs as fast as he could, climbing his way up to his floor. Deku trailed after him obediently.

However, such a sudden movement after spending days in the infirmary wasn't exactly good for Katsuki's back, which started aching terribly with each step he took. Every muscle in his body was trembling from the effort it took climbing the stairs, which made him feel more pathetic than ever. One hit to the head and now he couldn't even climb some fucking stairs? That was ridiculous. He was *Katsuki Bakugou*, for fuck's sake. He wasn't about to be taken down by some fucking stairs.

"You okay, Kacchan?", Deku asked, worry evident in his tone as he watched Katsuki stop mid-climb and lean slightly on the wall beside him. He was hunched over in a weird position, as if his back ached terribly. His hands balled into fists upon Deku's words.

"I'm *fine*", he growled through gritted teeth, his angry tone telling Deku that he would have his face blasted if he asked anymore questions. Just as Katsuki managed to pull himself together and stand with his back straight again, Tokoyami appeared at the bottom of the stairs. He studied Katsuki with a conflicted look before slowly, calmly continuing his way up and standing before the panting boy.

"Do you need me to get Recovery Girl?", he asked simply. Not *are you okay*, or *do you need help* or any other bullshit Deku would probably feed him. No, Tokoyami was straightforward and didn't beat around the bush. He saw Katsuki had a problem and asserted what would be the best way to deal with it, whereas Deku would have fretted and flooded him with questions and *touched* him. God, he couldn't stand Deku touching him. He low-key wished he had ended up stuck with Tokoyami's soul instead – at least it would have been more tolerable.

"I'm good", Katsuki said through gritted teeth, ignoring the way his head was beginning to throb. God, the old lady had told him this would happen – she had spent a long, long time babbling about side effects, recovery time, and not feeling like himself for a while – but he hadn't actually taken her seriously until now.

Apparently not even *him* was immune to the aftermath of a concussion. Still, he couldn't let anyone know that. He pulled himself together again and climbed the rest of the stairs Tokoyami lingering beside him as if he was ready to catch him if he fell. However, once he realized Katsuki was managing well enough on his own, even if still a little hunched over, he decided there wasn't much left for him to do there.

"I imagine your discomfort is expectable, after the blow you took", he said. "But I do think you should talk to Recovery Girl if it continues".

Katsuki raised his head, anger showing in his crimson eyes. He didn't know why he was feeling angry. Tokoyami simply stared back at him, untroubled by Katsuki's glare.

"You don't have to worry", Tokoyami reassured him, even though Katsuki hadn't asked for it. "I won't tell anyone about this".

Before Katsuki could offer a response, Tokoyami turned around and walked away.

Katsuki watched as Tokoyami walked further away from him in the corridor, the distance he was putting between them gradually increasing. Beside him, Deku stared at him with expectation. Katsuki sighed and rolled his eyes. The nerd really wasn't dropping it, right?

"Hey. Bird-brain", Katsuki called just as Tokoyami was about to turn the corner. Tokoyami stopped on his tracks and looked at him, his face neutral apart from a sparkle of curiosity that took over his eyes. He waited silently for Katsuki to continue.

Maybe Deku would get off his back for a while if he did it. He was well aware that Tokoyami didn't have to help him, and yet he had done so anyway.

Katsuki didn't ask for it, though. He didn't owe him, or *anyone*. So why show gratitude for something he hadn't requested?

Still, would it really *hurt*?

Fuck Deku.

"Thanks", Katsuki said simply. Emotionlessly. His face was tilted to the side and his eyes refused to meet Tokoyami's as he said the dreaded word. It didn't taste as sour in his tongue as he had expected it to, and the fact that it didn't made him angry. Tokoyami nodded his acknowledgement.

"You're welcome", he said, and just like that, disappeared at the end of the corridor as he went back to his room.

From downstairs, Katsuki and Izuku could still hear the discussion Tokoyami had stirred, realizing that the raven boy had probably left it without neither of the three riled up friends realizing.

Turning around to finally head towards his own room, Katsuki spotted a wide, proud smile overtaking Deku's face, two ridiculous dimples appearing on freckled cheeks. His desire to wipe that stupid look off Deku's face was smothered by another feeling he couldn't really find a name for. He decided to roll his eyes in annoyance just not to lose the habit and shoved his hand on Deku's hair, ruffling the curls as roughly as he could before playfully shoving Deku away.

"Don't look so smug, nerd", Katsuki scoffed, walking past Deku without meeting his eyes. "I just did it so you'll get the hell off my case".

"*Did* it hurt, though?", Deku raised an eyebrow at him as if he had just made a terrific point. Katsuki fiddled with the inside of his pocket as he searched for the key to his bedroom.

"Don't push your damn luck", he growled under his breath. His head was starting to throb harder now that the promise of rest was just one door away, almost begging him just to fall on his bed and sleep. "Just because I was nice to him, it doesn't mean I'm gonna be nice to you. At least he did something to earn it", he pointed out.

“Oh, sure. All I did was save your life”, Deku had the nerve to be sarcastic. He had the nerve to shove it on Katsuki's face *and* be sarcastic *and chuckle* while he was at it. Katsuki’s fury burst like a dam.

Giving up on his search for the keys, he slammed Deku on the wall beside his door and pinned him against it with one forearm pressed to his chest. Deku's eyes widened in shock at the sudden movement, gasping and yelping in a way that sent a shiver down Katsuki's aching spine.

“Next time you wonder why I can't stand your fucking guts, make sure to remember how you gave me a lame speech about not doing it for recognition only to shove it at my face a minute later”, he growled, his face dangerously close to Deku's as he pushed him against the wall.

“S-Sorry, Kacchan”, Deku said, sounding sincere and confused. He even managed to look guilty – though there was no fear in his eyes, not even when Katsuki pressed harder against him only to see if he’d be able to earn that reaction. “I didn’t mean it like that. It was just a joke”, he raised his hands as well as he could with Katsuki pinning him against a wall, as a peace gesture.

“I don’t fucking think so”, Katsuki scoffed. “Jokes are supposed to be funny, and I'm not laughing. If you think you are so much better than me, at least have the balls to say it to my face, instead of pretending you don’t ”, he snarled.

“I don’t”, Deku said, eyes sparkling with a desperate need for comprehension. “I mean it. I’m not better than you”, he shook his head and swallowed dry. “But I will be”, he added confidently, tilting his chin up slightly in defiance. There was a familiar determination in his green eyes as he said the words, and even though Deku's sincerity decreased the sourness in his mood, it wasn’t enough to make him loosen his grasp against the boy.

“We'll see about that, shitty nerd”, Katsuki smirked dangerously, crimson eyes sparkling with challenge.

“But I mean it, Kacchan. I didn’t mean to shove it on your face, or anything like that, I swear”, Deku added, looking serious. “It’s just – you – you ruffled my hair, and I thought – you know. That you –“

“That we were *friends*?”, Katsuki scoffed, raising a mocking eyebrow at the boy beneath him. Deku’s face fell in something akin to disappointment, but he still nodded his head.

“Something like that”, he muttered, lowering his gaze with shame. Katsuki sighed and rolled his eyes.

“Look –“, he started, but a sound coming from the stairs caught his attention. Shit. He had almost forgotten about his shitty friends arguing downstairs, and the way he had been arguing with Deku in the middle of the hallway had probably caught some attention. Before anyone could reach the floor and find him there – before he was forced to deal with people and throw Tokoyami’s distraction on the trash –, Katsuki struggled to find his keys inside his pockets as fast as he could. “*Shit*”, he muttered under his breath as the footsteps on the stairs got closer.

“Kacchan!”, Deku called. Katsuki lifted his throbbing head to find the boy standing at the top of the stairs – probably the maximum distance he could get from Katsuki without dragging him along – and staring down, probably to see who was coming. “It’s Kirishima-kun!”, Deku announced.

“Oh, *fuck*”, Katsuki growled, because if there was one person who was even more annoying than Deku when it came to asking him questions and fretting over him, that person was *Kirishima*. He liked the guy – pretending to just tolerate him was way past Katsuki now –, but his lively personality would be just too much for him on that moment. Triumphantly finding his keys, Katsuki shoved them on the door and shoved it open at the exact same time Kirishima’s head popped at the stairs.

“Bakugou?”, he asked, sounding surprised to see him there. No one other than Tokoyami knew he had been cleared out from the medical bay. “What are you doing there?”, Kirishima frowned, concerned.

“Before you lose your shit, I didn’t run away, I got cleared out”, Katsuki explained, stepping inside his room. “Now I want to sleep, so goodnight”, he continued over his shoulder. He was in the middle of the process of closing the door of his bedroom when Kirishima basically manifested himself in front of him, having probably rushed his way from the stairs. Deku appeared right behind him, probably pulled by Katsuki as he entered the room.

“Wait!”, Kirishima held the door with one hand before Katsuki could close it, looking worried. “I mean – how are you, man? How’s your head? Why did you get cleared out at midnight? What did Recovery Girl say? Will you be ok? Is Midoriya ok? What are y–“

Before Kirishima could continue his endless torrent of questions, Katsuki rolled his eyes and slammed the door close at full force without bidding his friend another goodbye.

He could have tried to be nice to Kirishima in the same way he had been to Tokoyami, but he didn’t want Deku to get too spoiled.

Chapter End Notes

First, an explanation: I got way too caught up with college, work, and life in general, hence the horrible delay to update this story! For this, I am really sorry. Hopefully now that I'm free from college (for the time being), I'll be able to update more regularly!
Secondly, I'm not happy at all with this chapter. I didn't write it in the same way I wrote the others - I barely had time to breathe this past month and I had to use whatever little scraps of time I had in order to put this on paper. The following chapters will probably be better than this, and more consistent, too. Either way, I hope this is at least tolerable!
Thank you for reading and make sure to let me know what you guys think! All feedback is really appreciated, and I read all of your comments (I definitely plan on replying to them as soon as I have the time, so don't worry!)
Thanks for sticking with this story and I'll see you on the next chapter!!

(Also I just finished writing this at like 2am so please forgive me if there are any typos or something like that)

Chapter 5: Anger Out, Sorrow In

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

He turned on his side, hoping the new position would soothe the pain on his back. It worked for a few minutes, until it started hurting again.

Katsuki sighed.

He shifted on the bed and turned on his other side, never opening his eyes. The new position offered him relief, but again, it only lasted a few minutes.

Another sigh.

He lay on his back. On his stomach. On his side again. And then, on the other side. He placed a pillow beneath his back, then he threw it halfway across the room when it didn't help with the pain. In the end, he was lying flat on his mattress, no pillows, no cushions, nothing. Still, his back ached as if he had carried the weight of the world on it for the past three days.

"God *fucking* damn it!", he ended up growling through gritted teeth, the worry that he might wake Deku up not even crossing his mind as he buried his face on the crook of his arm and screwed his eyes shut. He ended up falling asleep at some point after the outburst, and when he regained consciousness, there was a streak of bright yellow light breaking the darkness of his room and his back *still fucking hurt.*

He hated the idea of going back to Recovery Girl. He had just been allowed to return to his classes and to his normal life – or at least as normal as it could get when there was a ghost pissing him off every second of the day –, he didn't want to head back to the infirmary less than one day after being released. He would just take some pain killers and stretch when he had free time. He was sure this stupid back ache was a result of him lying idly in bed for days.

The pain in his head was almost entirely gone, and the light didn't bother his eyes as much as it had a couple days prior. Turning on the bed in order to get up and ignoring the way his sore back protested at the movement, Katsuki found Deku sitting by the window, glancing at the world outside with something akin to longing in his eyes. He didn't notice Katsuki had woken up.

"Oi, Deku", Katsuki called, voice hoarse from sleep. He rubbed his eyes and stretched his shoulders in an attempt to make the pain better. Deku turned his head to stare at the waking boy, heavy bags beneath his eyes and shoulders hunched, as if he was extremely tired. Katsuki grimaced. "Yikes. You look like shit", he commented instead of saying whatever he had meant to say, earning a frown from Deku.

"So do you", he commented, sounding sincere, rather than teasing. Averting his attention from the window, he shifted so that he could take a proper look at Katsuki. "Did you have

trouble sleeping, Kacchan?"

"What does it matter to you?", Katsuki responded simply, standing up from the bed and doing his best not to let Deku see how much the movement was hurting him. He walked towards his bathroom, dragging Izuku with him in the process. He shut the door to prevent shitty Deku from sneaking, even though he knew the boy knew better than to do that. As he attended to nature's call, a sudden thought occurred to him. "Don't you feel the need to use the bathroom too, shitty Deku? Even in the state you're in?", he asked from inside the bathroom. It took Deku a few moments to answer.

"I think everything would just… phase through me", he responded, voice muffled by the door. Katsuki rolled his eyes as he flushed the toilet.

"I fucking know that, nerd. That's not what I asked", he replied, running the sink and washing his hands. "I asked if you *feel the need*, not if you can or can't go".

"Oh", Deku replied, and Katsuki could clearly picture his stupid freckled face flushing. "I… I don't think so. Not so far, at least. I think – maybe my body is – ah, you know –", he started to stutter, probably embarrassed to talk about that kind of subject with Katsuki, who rolled his eyes again.

"I don't care", Katsuki cut him off before he could continue embarrassing himself. "If you have to go to the bathroom, use the common one downstairs. I don't want you using mine", he announced. Deku didn't reply.

He poured toothpaste on his toothbrush and brushed his teeth, rubbing with as much strength as he could and screaming an eventual "DIE" or "FUCKING GERMS" in the process. When he stepped out of the bathroom after rinsing his mouth, Deku looked at him with what seemed to be like a humorous expression, as if he had been laughing his ass off just a moment before spotting Katsuki.

"The fuck is so funny?", he asked, walking right past Deku and grabbing himself some clothes. He really, really needed a shower. Deku lowered his eyes, but took a peek inside the bathroom anyway, spotting Katsuki's abused toothbrush.

"Kacchan, you shouldn't brush your teeth so hard", he commented, the hint of a laughter hidden behind his voice. Katsuki glared at him.

"Don't tell me what to do, asshole", he growled, walking into the bathroom again and closing the door at Deku's face. "While you're busy treating those disgusting cavities you must have, I'll be sitting at home enjoying my perfectly healthy teeth".

"But when you brush your teeth too hard you wear out the natural protection –", Deku tried to argue, only to be interrupted by Katsuki yanking the bathroom door open and popping his head out to glare at him. Deku noticed he was already shirtless, his well-defined abdomen standing out against the pitch-black of his sweatpants. Deku blushed and quickly averted his eyes from Katsuki's midsection.

“The fuck did I just say about telling me what to do?”, Katsuki growled angrily. “Don’t go around giving your stupid ass advice to people who didn’t ask for it. I’m going to take a shower now, and if I hear one single word from you while I’m at it I’m going to shove your head into that toilet so hard you’ll end up stuck in the piping. Are we clear?”, he raised one inquiring eyebrow at Deku, who sighed and slumped his shoulders.

“Ok, Kacchan”, he mumbled, stepping away from the bathroom door just as Kacchan slammed it close hard enough to wake up everyone in the dormitory.

Izuku paced around the room, thankful that Kacchan’s bedroom was small enough for him to wander around without ending up being pulled back towards the bathroom door while the other boy was still inside. As he heard the sound of water running, he felt more relaxed, knowing that as long as Katsuki was taking his shower, he was free to do what he wanted. Well, at least he was free to do what he *could* do, given his current limitations.

As much as Izuku wanted to take a peek at Katsuki’s stuff, he knew better than to do that – not only because his hands would phase right through things, but also because it was impolite to pry. He settled for taking as much information as he could without having to touch anything – he noticed how minimalistic the bedroom was, with only the essential furniture and decoration, and how everything apart from the bed was meticulously organized. There was a working desk by the window, a rolling chair, a minifridge, a small wardrobe and some training equipment piled up at the corner of the room.

The working desk didn’t have any photo frames – it only seemed to contain Katsuki’s notebooks, some reading books, his laptop and a pencil case. A small plant pot was set as close as possible to the window, but Izuku didn’t know enough about plants to be able to tell if that was real or plastic. The thought of Kacchan watering plants and taking care of them seemed strangely endearing to Izuku.

There wasn’t much he could see from the wardrobe or the minifridge, since he couldn’t quite open them to peek inside. The training equipment seemed very similar to Izuku’s own – some dumbbells, a few weights to be tied around the ankles, a punching bag (though Izuku couldn’t really figure out where Kacchan hung the bag from or why he even had one in the first place, since there were plenty available on their gym). After taking this quick assessment of Katsuki’s room, Izuku decided there was nothing left from him to do. He was about to go back to sitting by the window, like he had been doing before Kacchan woke up, when his eyes found the boy’s unmade bed.

After sleeping on the floor for so many days, the sight of that soft, comfortable mattress was so inviting that Izuku almost drooled. His back was killing him. He could barely sleep anymore because of it, and he was sure, at that moment, that if he lay down on a proper mattress, even if for a few minutes, even if for just the time it took Kacchan to finish his shower, the pain would probably be relieved.

Still, it felt weird – almost uncanny – to lay down at a friend’s bed without their knowledge or permission. On the top of everything, this was *Kacchan’s* bed, and he would probably fulfil his promise of shoving Izuku’s head in the toilet if he walked out of his shower and found *Deku*, of all people, lying down on his bed.

Still, his back was so achy. It was so sore. Maybe he could just lie down for a few minutes and, as soon as he heard Kacchan walking out, he could stand up and pretend it had never happened, right?

No, he couldn't do that. He couldn't lie down on Kacchan's bed without permission! It was weird!

His back throbbed as if protesting. *It's aching so bad*. It would be just for a few minutes. *Just so I can stretch out and relieve the pain*. Just for a bit.

Izuku sent the bathroom door a wary look, almost as if afraid Kacchan could know, somehow, what he was up to. Hearing the sound of the water still running and a few indiscernible growls from Kacchan, Deku sighed and decided that yeah, maybe just a couple minutes wouldn't hurt, and it wasn't like Kacchan ever needed to know what he had done.

He approached the bed hesitantly, as if afraid Kacchan would burst out of the bathroom any second with murder in his eyes. The water kept running.

Izuku sat down at the edge of the bed, holding his breath. His shoulders were tense and his ears were sharp, attentive to any indication that Kacchan had finished his shower. None came.

He slowly lay down on the bed, biting his lower lip in nervousness and stretching out on the mattress. His whole body was tense because of the apprehension he was feeling, but his muscles immediately relaxed as soon as he was spread out on the mattress.

The surface was so soft that it felt like it was swallowing him whole, and Izuku finally let out a relieved shaky breath, melting into it and closing his eyes. It felt like the tension that had been giving him pain dissipated, and the relief that took its place was so intense and sudden that he felt lightheaded. He was so content and relieved for something as simple as lying down that he didn't even bother to put any thought into why his body hadn't phased through the bed. In fact, if Izuku thought about it, he may have passed out for a couple of minutes from sheer exhaustion thanks to the overwhelmingly pleasing sensation of *not being in constant pain anymore*. It wasn't until he heard a loud bang coming from the bathroom and a muffled scream of "FUCK!!!" that he reopened his eyes. It sounded like Kacchan had slipped and fallen.

"K-Kacchan…?", Izuku asked hesitantly, propping himself up from the bed in high alert as soon as he heard the sound. When no reply came, he frowned, concern replacing whatever relief he had felt just a moment ago. "Kacchan? Are you okay?", he insisted, which probably caused the other boy to become very annoyed.

"*I'm fucking fine, mind your own business*!", Izuku heard Kacchan's muffled voice screaming from inside the bathroom. He didn't sound like he was in pain or in any sort of imminent threat, which made Izuku relax a bit again. Kacchan was tough. If he said he was fine… then Izuku knew better than to meddle with his life.

A memory of a young Kacchan staring up at him with a flushed face and unfocused eyes, slapping his hand away when he offered to help, losing balance and almost falling back to the floor flooded Izuku's head. They had been young, no older than 11, and Kacchan had long

since stopped referring to Izuku as his friend. When Izuku found him after school, he was sitting propped up against a wall, chin glued to his chest and limbs askew, looking like he had fallen and tried to lean his weight on the wall in order to get up, failing in the process.

Izuku remembered freaking out over the fallen Kacchan, only to have the boy attempt to punch him in the face for fretting too much (Kacchan never got the hit – he was too dizzy to do so –, but the fact that he had *tried* was enough to make Izuku feel a little heartbroken). Still, even after Kacchan slapped his hand away and bit out a series of angry remarks (*don't fucking touch me, I'm fine, don't need your help, shitty Deku, stay the hell away from me, I'm fine, I'm fine, I'm fine*), Izuku still passed his arm around his shoulder and dragged him to the infirmary. The fact that Kacchan didn't offer any resistance to being dragged is what's always freaked Izuku out the most about this story, even to this day.

He wasn't allowed to linger at the school's infirmary with Kacchan after his mother arrived, saying hello to Izuku and calling him a brat (even though she was way politer than her son would ever be), and ruffling his hair in that same playful way Kacchan did with him sometimes. A couple of days later, Izuku went back to ask the nurse what had been wrong with his friend, since the boy hadn't been to school since he was taken into her care. He learned that Kacchan had a severe infection, probably due to some cuts on his hands, and that he would have to stay away from school until he recovered.

Kacchan returned to school a week later, looking and acting like his normal self. When a series of curious students asked him what had happened, why he had missed a week worth of classes, why he had disappeared without a trace, Kacchan announced that he ended up hurting himself while fighting a bad guy on his way back to school – that he had overused his amazing quirk but that he was fine now, nothing to worry about, because his metabolism was superfast and he wouldn't be taken down so easily by some D-lister.

Sometimes, Izuku still remembered the way his heart nearly stopped upon seeing a fallen Kacchan on the middle of the hallway. He remembered how pale his face had been, how unfocused and lost his eyes had looked. He remembered the way Kacchan clung to the front of his shirt as he dragged him to the infirmary, whether in anger or in desperation, Izuku couldn't tell, not even years later. He remembered looking into Kacchan's crimson, rageful eyes when he returned to school, finding no trace of gratitude – not that he expected any – or remembrance inside them. For all Izuku knew, Kacchan had no idea he had been the one to find him and take him to the nurse – he had asked for secrecy, knowing that Kacchan would hate him even harder if he found out it had been Izuku who saved his life.

Izuku wished he could have kept this time a secret from Kacchan, too.

He remembered the way Kacchan had beat him on the same day he returned, tearing one of his favorite notebooks apart and exploding the abused pages before slam dunking it into the trash. He remembered the way Kacchan had mocked him, his friends hovering behind him and laughing loudly as Izuku tried to protect his head with his arms. He remembered expecting a blow, only to look up and find Kacchan walking away, bragging about his quirk and not even sparing the fallen Izuku another glance, as if he was nothing, as if he was a *deku*.

Funny enough, he didn't remember seeing any of Kacchan's friends around the hallway when he found him fallen there. Kacchan was probably thankful that there was no one else around to witness his moment of weakness, but Izuku thought it was a bit sad to be as lonely as Kacchan seemed to be sometimes, even when there were dozens of people around him offering him incessant praise.

He must have passed out from tiredness again, because when he opened his sluggish eyes, Kacchan was already out of the bathroom and wearing fresh clothes, taking something from inside his wardrobe and staring at Izuku from above his shoulder with an unreadable look – one that was suspiciously *not* angry.

It took Izuku's sleepy brain a few seconds longer than it should to realize that Kacchan was not only looking at him, but *seeing him lying down on his bed without permission*, and as soon as that realization dawned upon him, Izuku was shoving himself as far away from the mattress as he could, eyes widening and a series of muttered apologies rushing out of his lips before he could really think about it.

"Sorry Kacchan I didn't mean to I was just really tired and I didn't have anything to do because I can't really get too far without dragging you with me and it would have been weird if I had tried to sneak out and ended up dragging you out of your shower or having you naked in the middle of the hallway also your bed is really comfortable and inviting so I figured it wouldn't be a problem to just rest for a bit while I waited for you but I didn't mean to fall asleep I swear it just happened but it won't happen again I didn't even know I was asleep until I –"

Izuku's ranting was cut short when Katsuki crossed the distance between them and shoved his palm against Izuku's lips, a serious glare in his crimson eyes. He held his hand there as if he wanted to ensure Izuku wasn't going to continue his blabbering as soon as his lips were free. His hand smelled sweet like nitroglycerin.

"I can't tell whether you're an actual moron or just disrespectful as fuck", he commented. Izuku, unable to respond due to Katsuki's hand sealing his lips closed, merely stared up at him with big confused eyes. Katsuki, for once didn't look angry, just annoyed. "What the fuck did I tell you about *ranting*?"

Izuku made as if to respond, which resulted on Katsuki pressing his hand harder against his lips.

“Don’t answer that, shitty Deku”, he scoffed, taking a step closer to Izuku. Their bodies were almost glued to each other’s in the small bedroom, but Katsuki stood tall and intimidating above him. He continued to glare at Izuku for several moments, looking like he was trying to decide what to do with him, until he finally let go and removed his hand from Izuku’s face, shoving the boy slightly away in the process. He turned away from the Izuku, who was starting to blush, and went back to doing whatever he had been doing before Izuku woke up. “But I do agree with you –“, he continued, not bothering to look at Izuku as he spoke, “my bed’s fucking amazing. I wouldn’t sleep in it if it wasn’t”.

Izuku suppressed the urge to roll his eyes. Classic Kacchan.

“Still, I don’t give a rat’s ass whatever shitty reason you had for sleeping in it”, he shrugged, much to Izuku’s surprise. He had actually thought Kacchan would blast his ass into the atmosphere if he caught him sleeping on his bed – and yet, he seemed to be untroubled by it. Now that Izuku paid attention, he could see that Kacchan was standing up straighter and looking more well-rested. “You look like you could use the rest, if the ugly-as-fuck bags beneath your eyes are anything to go by”, he spared Izuku a quick glimpse from above his shoulder. “Also, I’m feeling better after the hot shower I took, so I’ll be benevolent and won’t kick your ass this time. But if you *ever* tell *anyone* about this –“, he turned just so that he could point a threatening finger at Izuku.

“I won’t!”, Izuku immediately responded. “I – I promise”.

“Yeah, you *won’t* if you know what’s good for you”, Katsuki scoffed, turning his back on Izuku again and shutting the door of his wardrobe.

“I – I thought you would be mad at me”, Izuku admitted, frowning as he watched Kacchan gather his things into his backpack and get ready for class. “For – s-sleeping in your bed uninvited”, he shrugged awkwardly. Katsuki stopped what he was doing – shoving his notebook inside his backpack – and looked at him again, a cold, calculating look in his crimson, burning eyes. There was something off about this whole interaction. Kacchan looked calmer than usual and, after knowing the boy for so many years, *calm Kacchan* could only mean trouble. Izuku low-key wished the boy would go back to screaming and pushing already – having him stare at Izuku with such a calculating look in his eyes was uncanny.

“Like I said, you look like you could use the rest”, Kacchan said, almost as if he wanted Izuku to read some hidden meaning into his words. His eyes were studying the boy in front of him with sharp attention. “Also”, he shrugged after a few moments, closing his backpack and throwing it over his shoulder. “There’s a theory I want to test”.

“A – A theory?”, Izuku asked, frowning. He followed Katsuki as he headed to the door. “What do you mean?”

“You’ll find out when it’s time”, Katsuki said without looking at him, stepping out and holding the door open for Izuku. Once the ghost boy was out, Katsuki closed the door to his bedroom and locked it with his personal key. He had *really* nosy friends. “Oh, and don’t talk to me when we’re in public”, Katsuki added as an afterthought, throwing the key up and catching it midair before shoving it into his pocket. “No one else can see you, so it will look weird if people see me talking to nothing. I don’t want any more extras thinking I’m a

nutcase", he grunted, going down the stairs. "Also, you're annoying as fuck and I don't want to hear your voice", he added just not lose habit. This time, Izuku did roll his eyes.

Izuku was about to explain to Kacchan that he didn't really think he would manage staying quiet for so long, especially since they would be attending class together and he always had hundreds of questions, but his thoughts came to a halt when he realized the common room and the kitchen were empty. That was weird. Their friends should at least be up and about, but there wasn't a single soul to be seen. Trying to keep up with Kacchan's fast pace in order to avoid being dragged by their invisible bond, Izuku managed to catch a glimpse of the watch hanging on the kitchen wall. They were an hour early to class.

"Kacchan", Izuku frowned, struggling to keep up with his fast pace. "Why are we going to class so early?"

"None of your business. Now shut the fuck up", was Kacchan's simple response. Izuku decided not to push it. As much as Kacchan's calmness was unsettling, he found out he didn't want it to go away just yet, and asking him questions was bound to annoy him and shove him right back into his usual sour mood. Therefore, Izuku did his best to stay quiet as they slowly strolled across the UA headquarters.

The stroll took longer than Izuku expected it to, and it took him longer than it should to realize that Kacchan was actually *enjoying* it. Staring at his friend's grumpy face, Izuku came to understand that Kacchan had left the dorms early just so that he could take his time making his way to class. The possibility that Kacchan was just trying to avoid their friends asking questions for as long as he could didn't go unconsidered by Izuku, but now that he put some thought into it, he couldn't remember one single day when he had arrived to class and Kacchan hadn't been there. He was always the first one to arrive.

A soft smile appeared on Izuku's lips. It felt nice, getting to know the nuances of Kacchan's personal habits like that. They had known each other for a lifetime, and there were still so many secrets to unfold.

Izuku wished he could unfold them all. He wished he could actually be friends with Kacchan.

"*What*?", Kacchan's harsh tone broke him out of his thoughts. Izuku looked up at him, confused.

"Huh?", he ended up asking, not really understanding the reason behind the boy's question.

"You were smiling like a fucking idiot and then you started to look like someone shoved shit inside your nose", Kacchan scoffed. He didn't look interested on the reason behind Izuku's sudden sadness, just curious about it.

You seem to be under the impression that we're friends now, just because I can't get rid of you, even though I have told you time and time again we're anything but.

Izuku turned his head away so that Kacchan couldn't see the sadness in his eyes, shrugging like the subject wasn't important. He knew precisely what would happen if he told Kacchan the truth – that he was upset because, no matter how hard he tried to be close to Kacchan, he

always ended up shoving him away like he was nothing, like he was a deku, and that broke Izuku's heart – Kacchan would mock him, or call him a sentimental loser, or quite possibly beat him up. He was better off being quiet.

Kacchan continued to stare at him for a few moments, waiting for a response, but when Izuku offered none, he scoffed and rolled his eyes.

"*Tch*. Whatever", he shrugged, and picked up his pace. Izuku was forced to follow him, noticing how Kacchan seemed much better in comparison to the night prior. A few hours before, he could barely go up the stairs without help – now, he was almost jogging his way to class, Izuku struggling to keep up with him.

When they arrived at the classroom, it was – as expected – empty. Kacchan made his way to his assigned seat and Izuku sat directly behind him, fingers drumming hesitantly at the surface of his desk. He couldn't bring any material with him, since everything other than Kacchan just phased through him, so there was no way he would be able to take notes during class. He could only hope one of his friends would be considerate enough to take notes for him while he was in his situation – surely, Kacchan wouldn't bother, so Izuku wasn't going to ask him. Still, it was a bit unsettling, being in class and not bringing any notebooks or pens with him. He felt stripped bare, as if he was an outsider, or as if there was something very important missing – quite possibly, his body. He wasn't even in his uniform, for god's sake – he didn't feel like he belonged in that room.

Now that Izuku thought about it, the clothes he was wearing weren't his hero costume, either – he figured it would only make sense for his soul to be wearing the last clothes his body had been wearing when they were disconnected. However, that wasn't the case. The clothes he was wearing were casual, something he would wear on his everyday life – a T-shirt that was years and years old and that had been given to him by his mother, and a pair of jeans that All Might had given to him after his own got destroyed beyond repair during one of his many training sessions with One For All. His shoes were the same as always – the only thing in his life that didn't seem to change.

Even though he didn't know why, it bothered him that he was wearing these clothes, and not his hero costume. He loved the shirt, and the pants All Might gave him, but it didn't make any sense. He should be in his uniform, which were the last clothes his body had been wearing during the fight, or at least in the hideous hospital gown that Recovery Girl had shoved on him back at the medical bay. It wasn't logical for him – for his soul – to be dressed like this.

Perhaps it had to do with emotional attachment? Maybe he loved these clothes so much – one, a gift from his mom, the other, from All Might, and the shoes were beyond description – that his soul had immediately gone for them – or a representation of them – when it needed. Still, it didn't make any sense. What did emotional attachment have to do with anything? Why would it interfere with the clothes he was stuck with? That wasn't logical at all.

A sudden thought occurred to him.

If emotional attachment was an actual factor that interfered with what his soul could or could not do, why was it that he could only touch Kacchan, and nobody else?

“If you think I won’t punch your teeth in if you keep up with this muttering, you’re dead mistaken”, Katsuki growled furiously from the seat in front of him, not turning around to face Izuku as he spoke. To be fair, Izuku hadn’t even realized he was muttering – which was something that happened more often than he liked to admit.

“S-Sorry, Kacchan”, Izuku stuttered nervously, face flushing a bright red thanks to his sudden epiphany. Surely, he liked Kacchan a lot, despite of all the mistreatment he received from the boy – still, was it enough to make him the only person his soul could have contact with? What about All Might and his mom? They hadn’t been able to touch him.

No, this couldn’t be it. The reason he could touch Kacchan had to do with the villain’s quirk, and that alone. Whatever he may or may not feel had nothing to do with it. His admiration for Kacchan wasn’t bigger than for All Might, and he didn’t love Kacchan more than he loved his mom! That was absurd!

His stomach twisted. Was it really that absurd? Could he love Kacchan more than he loved his mom? Even with all the bullying and name-calling and abuse?

No! That just wasn’t possible. There was no one he loved more than his mom!

But what if they were different types of love? The love he felt for his mom and for All Might was fraternal, but there was no reason why his love for Kacchan would be so. Maybe different types of love earned different results? Was that why his soul was wearing things that his mom and All Might had given to him, even if they couldn’t see him? Was that why he could touch Kacchan? No, that couldn’t be it. It *had* to do with the villain’s quirk. It couldn’t have to do with his love for Kacchan!

Izuku’s eyes widened and the red in his face was thoroughly renewed as he came to the realization that he did not, not even once, doubt that he *loved* Kacchan in the first place, however that love may present itself.

Where did his admiration end and his love begin? Everything was so confusing that his mind felt like it was spiraling, stuck in a whirlpool of confusing emotions and feelings that he couldn’t figure out and that strangely didn’t feel entirely like his own. He didn’t even notice when Kacchan stood up from his seat angrily, shoving one of his hands on the front of Izuku’s shirt and yelling something at his face.

“I’M THIS CLOSE FROM DUCTAPING YOUR STUPID GHOST MOUTH SHUT YOU PIECE OF SHIT, I CAN BARELY STAND YOUR MUTTERING ON A NORMAL DAY BUT I REFUSE TO BE THE ONLY ONE FORCED TO HEAR IT! YOU EITHER SHUT THE HELL UP FOR GOOD OR IMMA SHOVE YOUR SHITTY HOSPITAL BLANKET DOWN YOUR BODY’S THROAT SO HARD THAT IT WILL COME OUT YOUR ASS!”

A noise at the door caught their attention, making Izuku and Katsuki turn towards it at the same time. There, stood Todoroki, looking as neutral as ever and suspiciously untroubled by the fact that he had just walked in on Katsuki screaming at nothing in the middle of their empty classroom.

They stared at each other for a long time, Katsuki's eyes widening slightly as if in embarrassment for being caught in such a position, while Todoroki managed to look unconcerned and disapproving at the same time, if that was even possible. After a few awkward seconds, in which Katsuki continued to cling to the front of Izuku's shirt while Todoroki continued to stand unmoving by the door, the explosive boy finally let go of Izuku, shoving him back and standing up straight with a furious look.

"The fuck you looking at, Icy Hot?", he shouted, irritated. Much to his annoyance, Todoroki simply ignored him and stepped into the room, heading for his seat in absolute silence. "Yeah. Go the fuck ahead and ignore me, you bastard. See if I care", he growled. Todoroki took his seat calmly and only then raised an eyebrow at Katsuki.

"It's hard to think you *don't* care when you keep screaming over everything", he commented with indifference, no mocking or teasing in his tone – he was merely making an observation. However, the coldness of his remark only made Katsuki angrier, and tiny explosions began to pop at his palms. Izuku, completely forgetting his own embarrassment from the weight of his epiphany, immediately placed himself between Katsuki and Todoroki, even though only one of the boys could see him do that.

"Kacchan!", Izuku shouted, outstretching his arms as if to shield Todoroki from the boy's possibly incoming explosions.

"Get the hell out of my way, Deku", he snarled, averting his eyes from Todoroki and towards the boy standing in front of him. "If the Half'n'Half bastard wants beef with me, beef's what he's gonna get", he tried to walk past Izuku – to do what, he didn't know; it wasn't like he could simply murder Todoroki in the middle of their classroom –, but the boy blocked Kacchan's way once more.

"Just – go back to your seat, Kacchan", Izuku pleaded, not wanting his friend to get in trouble over nothing. "Aizawa sensei will arrive any minute now, and you'll get in trouble if he sees you fighting –"

"How is Midoriya holding up?", Todoroki interrupted, unaware that Izuku had been speaking in the first place. He continued to stare up at Katsuki with indifference, which only served to annoy him, but it was his *question* that annoyed him the most, for some reason. Not the fact that he had ignored Katsuki's anger to ask him something, but the question itself.

"Why the *hell* do you care, asshole?", Katsuki asked, managing to take a step past Izuku and towards Todoroki.

"Because he is my friend", Todoroki explained simply, as if that was obvious. Katsuki did his best to ignore the way Deku's face became all flushed at the remark, closing his hands into fists. "Also, he didn't look exactly healthy back in the medbay. I wanted to make sure you aren't putting too much strain on him".

"What the fuck do you mean, Icy Hot bastard?!", Katsuki exploded, offended. "How the *fuck* would I be straining him?!"

“You were just yelling at him”, Todoroki commented absentmindedly. “Though I am sure we have all grown used to your moods by now, I don’t think this is earning a positive effect on Midoriya. Recovery Girl said his charts have been acting weird”.

“How the hell do you even know that?”, Katsuki snarled, subtly defecting Todoroki’s accusation. “You’ve been standing vigil by the nerd’s bedside or something?”

Todoroki averted his eyes from Katsuki, even if he didn’t look embarrassed per say.

“I have been visiting him”, Todoroki admitted, managing to look as casual as ever. “We all have”.

Katsuki rolled his eyes and huffed out of his nose as if he thought that was the most ridiculous thing that could ever happen. He turned his head to look at Deku, who looked very flustered and very sad at the same time.

“T-T-Thank you, Todoroki-kun”, he said, voice barely above a whisper as he lowered his head in embarrassment. Todoroki, obviously, didn’t hear him, and Izuku knew better than to ask Katsuki to relay the message to him.

“We are all worried about him”, Todoroki added after Katsuki did nothing other than glare at Deku’s general direction. “Since you are the only one who can communicate with him, I think you could at least do something to ease your friends’ worries. It would cost you nothing”, he concluded. Katsuki snarled.

“Don’t tell me what to do, Icy Hot”, he spat, turning on his heels and heading back towards his own seat.

“Bakugou”, Todoroki called, standing up from his chair calmly. Katsuki stopped on his tracks, looking at the boy from above his shoulder.

A long time passed without neither of the boys saying anything, a tense silence stretching between the two of them while Izuku could do nothing other than watch. Todoroki looked like he was trying to decide whether he should speak up his thoughts or not. It felt like an eternity before he finally continued.

“I know you worry about him too. I believe it would be good for him to let him know that”, he ended up saying, looking as neutral as ever. Katsuki, on the other hand, snapped so hard at the statement that there was smoke coming out of his palms.

“Oh, *yeah*?”, he snarled, marching his way back to where Todoroki was standing, looking ready to attack. “You saw one shitty footage and you think you *know me*? You think you know shit about me and Deku, you Half’n’Half asshole?”, he grabbed the front of Todoroki’s uniform and pulled at it angrily.

“Kacchan!”, Izuku protested, eyes widening in surprise at the turn of events. “Let him go!”

“You’re not a difficult person to read”, Todoroki said simply, unbothered by Katsuki’s sudden movements. He slapped the boy’s hand away from his uniform as if it was nothing and

continued to stare at him, this time the hint of a glare appearing in his eyes. “I couldn’t spend hours analyzing your personality based only on what little interaction we’ve had so far, but I am not going to do that. I am not telling you this for your sake – it’s for Midoriya’s”, he added coldly. “He admires you and looks up to you, we all know that. You may not admire him at all, but I do know you at the very least don’t want him to die. Whether you like it or not, you are stuck with him until the villain is captured, which gives you part of the responsibility for his well-being. If you mistreat him, the after effects show on his body, and if anything happens to him because you were too much of a dick to actually be thankful to the person who saved your life – you will have to answer to *a lot* of people who care about him. Not just me”, he concluded. Izuku’s face was as red and bright as a tomato.

“Are you *threatening* me?”, Katsuki scoffed, a wicked half-grin half-snarl appearing on his face. “Am I supposed to be *scared* at your little display of heroics?”

“No”, Todoroki responded. “I was simply stating a fact”.

“Listen to me, asshole”, Katsuki took a step closer to Todoroki, who continued to look unbothered. “Deku isn’t a fucking helpless maiden who needs a loser like your double-colored ass to defend his honor. If he’s got a problem with me, he can tell it to my face”, he snapped his head to the side to stare at the flustered Deku, pointing a finger at him. “You hear me, douchebag? Say it to my face if you’ve got a problem with me!”. Izuku’s eyes widened even further and he nodded his head frantically in agreement.

“That’s reassuring”, Todoroki commented, his tone so plain that no one could tell if he was being sarcastic or actually serious.

“I don’t give a *shit* what you think”, Katsuki snapped his head back at Todoroki. “Just stay out of my fucking way and stop telling yourself you know *anything* about me and Deku. Stupid piece of shit”, he muttered under his breath as he walked away from the boy once again.

“I was serious about informing Midoriya’s friends of his state”, Todoroki added, but this time, Katsuki didn’t stop or look back.

“I’m sure you were”, he said simply, throwing himself on his seat and putting both his legs above his desk in a disrespectful manner. Todoroki looked like he wanted to say something else but, before he could, Iida and Uraraka entered the room, their heads turned towards each other’s as they spoke in a low voice. Uraraka was the first one to see Katsuki sitting there, and her big eyes widened as they found him.

“Bakugou-kun!”, she exclaimed, rushing towards him and leaving a confused Iida behind. Katsuki rolled his eyes and sighed, but did nothing as the girl approached him. Iida was fast behind her, actually speaking up before she had the chance.

“Bakugou! How is your head?”, he asked, standing beside the girl.

“How is Deku-kun? Is he okay? He looked a bit tired when I visited this morning…”

“Were you cleared out by Recovery Girl? I didn’t see you return to our dorms. You didn’t run away from the medical bay, did you?”

“Please tell Deku-kun I have been taking notes for him so that he doesn’t fall behind when he is out of the medical bay! I would have taken notes for you too, but Kirishima-kun said he would do that…”

“I have been taking notes for you and Midoriya as well! As class representative, that is my duty! I also need to know how your head is doing! Ensuring the well-being of my colleagues is my responsibility, and I need to know in case I need to call for Recovery Girl’s assistance –“

“Is Deku-kun ok? Did he have any ideas how we can –“

“I must ask you to inform me should you feel any discomfort or something unusual –“

“ – said you could touch, so I’m sure there are a lot of things about this villain’s quirk we still need to figure out –“

“ – only in case of an emergency. Are you sure you should be in class so soon? Kirishima said –“

“ – but I’m sure Deku-kun can figure it out! If there’s someone –“

“ – either way, don’t hesitate to call. We are all –“

“Kacchan, are you okay?”

“ – maybe give him some space…”

“ – I mean, if you want to, you can take a look at my notes too, there’s no problem –“

“Yo, guys! Blasty’s back! Did you know that?”

“Oh, shit, I hope he didn’t run away –“

“ – my personal number, so that won’t be a problem in case you feel ill –“

“ – just tell Deku-kun we miss him and we wish him best! I – I hope he gets –“

“Kacchan, you’re scaring me!”

Everything went silent.

Katsuki opened his eyes.

(When had he closed them?)

He was panting, standing up, hands leaning heavily on his desk, which had its sides scorched – probably thanks to Katsuki’s palms. His head was pounding and sweat was rolling down his

temples, sweet and cold. His stomach was churning. He was feeling way too many emotions at the same time. His hands were starting to pop. He needed to get out of there.

He looked up. Round Face and Four Eyes were staring at him, her with terrified eyes and him with a concerned look. Behind him, Todoroki was eyeing him with similar concern, even if it was better hidden in his stoic face. Closer to the door were Sero, Kaminari, and Kirishima, all looking equally scared and worried about him. His head turned to find Deku, who had a hand on his shoulder. Katsuki didn't remember when Deku touched him, but he was almost sure it was at the same time when the noises finally died down.

At the front of the room, there were a chair and a desk, completely destroyed and still fuming. Katsuki didn't have to put much effort into realizing he had been the one to do that, even though he couldn't remember doing it.

His crimson eyes ran across the room again. Too many people. Too many questions. Just as he had expected. Just as he had dreaded.

Without thinking too much about it, he picked up his backpack, which had been silently scorched by his explosions, threw it over his shoulder and headed towards the exit. Round Face and Four Eyes stepped aside to let him go through, and Katsuki didn't meet their eyes as he went. His heart was still pounding. His fight-or-flight instincts had been activated, even though he couldn't figure out why.

Just before he walked out of the door, without looking at anyone's faces, he said simply:

"You. Shitty Hair. With me".

He didn't look behind him to see if Kirishima was following him.

(He didn't look to see if Deku was following him either, but he didn't have to).

He headed to the gym, trying his best to calm his frantic mind and ease his screaming thoughts, controlling his breathing in order to make his heart stop trying to rip itself off his chest.

"Bakugou, Aizawa-sensei will arrive any minute now –", Kirishima tried to protest as he entered the gym right after Katsuki. Deku was standing hesitantly between the two of them, not sure of what to do with himself. He couldn't get his eyes off Katsuki, worry etched in green.

“I fucking know that, and he won’t kick you out for missing two minutes of his class or some shit. I just need you to do something, then you can go”, Katsuki replied with annoyance, throwing his backpack on the floor and turning around to face Kirishima. Given the fact that Katsuki-asking-for-a-favor was something extremely rare and quite possibly unprecedented in human history, Kirishima placed his backpack on the floor as well and nodded, determination clear in his eyes. This was probably a very serious subject, and given the scene Katsuki had just made back in the classroom when he started exploding things with that panicked look on his face, Kirishima wasn’t about to walk out on his friend just because of his fear of being late to class.

“All right, bro”, he said simply, slapping his hands together and nodding emphatically. “Whatever you need”.

“Punch me in the fucking face”, Katsuki said in a deadpan.

Silence.

“Uh… *What*?”, Kirishima asked after several moments.

“You heard me, asshole, and I ain’t repeating myself”, Katsuki scoffed, turning to look at Deku. “Remember I told you you’d find out about my theory? This is the time, so pay fucking attention”, he gestured at Kirishima to approach. “Come on. Deck me as hard as you can”.

“B-Bakugou, I think you should talk to Recov–“

“For fuck’s sake, can you all just stop trying to push me back to the old hag for once and quit the bullshit?”, he interrupted, annoyed. “Just do as I fucking said, c’mon! I know you and half the class have been dying for the chance of punching me, so if you’re too much of a pussy to do it, I’ll just call in someone else”, he grumbled.

“Kacchan, maybe you should –“

“Shut up, shitty Deku. Are we doing this or what?”, he raised his eyebrows at Kirishima.

“Dude”, Kirishima said, frowning and shaking his head. “I’m not punching you”.

“Why the fuck not?”, Katsuki scoffed.

“Because you’re not well”, Kirishima took a step closer to him, looking deeply concerned. “You just got cleared out of the hospital after spending days there because of a severe concussion. You look like you just had a panic attack *and* you destroyed a desk out of nowhere. You look like you haven’t been sleeping for days. I – I’m just not doing it, man. You’re not ok”.

“Don’t tell me what the *fuck* I am”, Katsuki grabbed the front of Kirishima’s shirt and shoved him hard. “Just punch me in the fucking *face*”, he said through gritted teeth, trying to strike Kirishima and force him into a fight. Kirishima skillfully dodged the blow, his skin hardening on instinct.

“Bakugou, *stop*”, he protested, blocking another well-aimed blow.

“Kacchan, what are you doing?! Stop!”, Izuku protested, throwing himself on Katsuki and trying to pull him away from Kirishima.

“Get off me!”, Katsuki yelled, shoving Deku back.

“Dude, just stop it!”, Kirishima said, trying to hold Katsuki down as well. Katsuki punched him, hitting his shoulder and sending the boy back with a surprised yelp. “*Stop* trying to fight me! I’m not punching your face!”

Katsuki got back to his feet from where he had fallen to his knees, still frantic and disoriented. He ran the back of his hand on his upper lip to clear the sweat away, glaring at Kirishima.

“I’m not fucking crazy, you moron”, he said, sounding slightly more lucid than before. “I’m just trying to figure something out. About the connection I have with Deku”, he explained. Deku’s eyes widened.

“W-What? What are you talking about, Kacchan?!”, he asked, clearly nervous.

“Yeah? And decking you helps you do that *how*, exactly?”, Kirishima asked, fists raised ready to defend himself from another possible blow.

“If I’m right, then you’ll see it”, Katsuki argued. “If I’m wrong – well, then you’ll be about the only person in the world who’s had the satisfaction to actually punch me in the face”, he smirked. Kirishima didn’t seem to find this humorous.

“That wouldn’t be a satisfaction, man”, he frowned. “You’re my friend. It’s one thing to spar with you, but punching you in the face after you just got cleared out isn’t the same”.

“God, you’re such a fucking *coward*”, Katsuki scowled. “I should have asked Pikachu instead”.

“Dude! I’m not about to get my ass suspended for making your concussion worse!”, Kirishima tried to defend himself, looking offended.

“You think so much of yourself, huh, Shitty Hair?”, Katsuki growled, approaching Kirishima again. The boy tensed up, as did Deku. “You think one of your shitty punches is gonna do what? Send me to the hospital? As *if*”, he scoffed.

“Kacchan”, Izuku said with a warning in his voice, realizing what Katsuki was doing. He was provoking Kirishima into punching him.

“You *wish* you had enough power to do that”, Katsuki scoffed.

“Dude. Stop. I’m not falling for that”, Kirishima shook his head again, looking skeptical.

“You keep blabbering about how you’re going to support me and be there for me as if you were my friend or some shit but the *moment* I ask you for a favor you bail”, Katsuki growled.

“*Kacchan*”, Izuku said, sounding infinitely more serious. “Don’t do this. Kirishima-kun is actually your friend –“

“I should have asked someone who actually has balls. God, Half’n’Half was probably dying to punch my teeth in but I decided to waste my time with *you*”, he shook his head.

“*Kacchan!*”

“Bakugou”, Kirishima said, looking suspiciously hurt by that conversation. “Stop it. I’m not hurting you”.

“I don’t even know why the fuck I let you hang around me, if you’re such a weak-ass –“

Katsuki didn’t have the chance to finish the phrase as a fist collided with his face and sent him falling on his butt.

He took a hand to his aching jaw with a victorious smirk, but, to his surprise, Kirishima was standing exactly at the same place, looking like he hadn’t moved an inch. His eyes were wide in confusion and surprise as he stared at the fallen Katsuki, clearly clueless to what had happened.

Turning his head, Katsuki found Deku fallen on the floor right beside him, one hand cradling his own jaw and the other still balled into a fist.

Deku had been the one who punched him, the little *shit*.

But most importantly, just as Bakugou had expected to prove, Deku was also *feeling the pain from his own punch*.

His theory was right. The bond connecting was also making them feel each other’s pain.

Which was probably why Katsuki’s back wouldn’t stop *fucking aching* and the little piece of shit didn’t even consider bringing up the amount of pain he had been in, forcing Katsuki to deal with it as well!

“You *bastard*!”, Katsuki yelled, not at Kirishima but at Deku.

“Sorry, Kacchan, but I couldn’t let you be so mean to Kirishima-kun –“, Deku tried to explain, looking angry and determined, but Katsuki interrupted before he could continue his lame speech.

“Why the *fuck* didn’t you tell me you were in fucking pain?!”, he shouted. “I’ve been dealing with your shitty backache the entire goddamn time because you just couldn’t put some use into your trap for fucking once!”

“Dude”, Kirishima said with an anguished expression on his face. This was the second time he bore witness to a one-sided argument between Katsuki and an invisible Izuku. “I have no idea what’s going on”.

“W-What? What are you talking about?!”, Izuku asked, equally confused.

“If you feel the pain I feel, then *I* feel the pain *you* feel, too!”, Katsuki pointed a finger at him. “If you had just said something about your shitty back, we could have done something about it instead of you having me walk around like fucking Quasimodo this entire fucking time!”

“Wait”, Izuku frowned, retrieving his hand from his aching jaw and frowning. “Your – your back was aching too?”

“*Yes*, dipshit”, Katsuki shook his head in disbelief. “God, you’re such a dumbass. And you probably haven’t been sleeping because of it, which means *I* haven’t been sleeping because of it, and know we’re both sleep-deprived *losers* because of your inability to communicate!”

“Hey!”, Izuku protested, offended. “You are the one who tried to talk Kirishima-kun into punching you in the face to prove a point when you could have literally just *asked* me if my back was aching!”

“Shut the hell up!”, Katsuki responded, feeling embarrassed by the truth behind Izuku’s point but not willing to demonstrate it.

“Bakugou, seriously, this talking-to-Midoriya-as-if-there’s-no-one-else-around thing is really confusing”, Kirishima protested. “I have no idea what’s going on right now. Did Midoriya just punch you in the face? What do you mean you are feeling each other’s pain?”

Katsuki ran both hands across his face, angry, and scratched his scalp before getting back to his feet with a muffled scream of anger. Kirishima was staring at him with a half-hurt, half-concerned look, and Katsuki rolled his eyes in annoyance before approaching him again.

“Look, Shitty Hair, I’m gonna make this quick because I’m not in the mood for this Q&A bullshit everyone seems to be pulling at me”, he said, straight to the point. Izuku, who had also stood up and was approaching the pair, pointed him with a disapproving look, which made Katsuki roll his eyes again. “Fine. *Kirishima*. Whatever”, he sighed. “Yeah, I get this whole Ghost Deku thing is confusing as hell and probably makes me look like a fucking nutcase, but I’m having a hard time catching up too, ok? You’re not the only one who’s confused as fuck. I just found out the reason why I’ve been feeling like death warmed over these past days is because Deku has been feeling like that, and we apparently share pain, too, because the shitty-ass quirk that connected our souls is literally the worst thing ever. And yeah. Me and Deku are soulbound or some bullshit”, he added upon Kirishima’s very shocked look. “What I mean is – Deku is a fucking asshole –“

“Hey!”, Izuku protested.

“ – who didn’t tell me he was feeling like shit –“

“You would have told me to shut up if I had said something!”

“ – and now I can’t figure out if what I’m feeling is what *I’m* feeling or if it’s what *he’s* feeling”, he turned his head to glare at Deku, who fell silent for once. “I can’t do anything without this asshole trailing behind me –“

“Not out of my own free will”.

“ – and he *keeps talking over me* because he’s a piece of shit who knows you can’t hear him and he thinks that makes the interruptions excusable”, he glared at Deku again.

“Sorry”, Izuku lowered his eyes, falling silent.

“Anyway. You should get going to class now”, Katsuki scoffed, earning a surprised look from Kirishima. “Aizawa sensei is probably already there”.

“Wait. You’re not going?”, he asked with a frown.

“Nah, I’m gonna talk to Recovery Girl”, Katsuki explained, looking grumpy. He didn’t want to go back to the old woman’s infirmary so soon after being released, but now that he knew the cause behind his discomfort – and now that he knew that the discomfort wasn’t a result of his own weakness, but of *Deku’s* – he didn’t feel as uncomfortable asking for her help. Still, the remark earned a shocked look from both Kirishima and Izuku alike. Angry, he protested: “What? Isn’t that what both of you assholes wanted? I’m finally figuring my shit out *and* I’m going to talk to the old woman and take care of myself. You two should be throwing a fucking *party* instead of giving me those looks”.

“Kacchan, taking care of yourself is not something awardable. It’s a basic requirement”, Izuku pointed out with an almost sad look, even though there was a hint of a humorous smile on his face.

“Shut up, Deku!”, Katsuki shouted at him.

“Why would we throw you a party for something you’re supposed to do, bro?”, Kirishima raised an eyebrow. Katsuki fumed, while Izuku chuckled out loud.

“You make sure your shitty soul gets stuck to Shitty Hair’s next time, dumbfuck”, Katsuki shoved his fingers on Izuku’s curly hair and ruffled it aggressively before pushing his head away. Izuku yelped in half-surprise, half-pain.

“Why? Does Midoriya agree with me?”, Kirishima grinned, pleased with himself. “I’m *sure* he does”.

“*Of course* he does”, Katsuki rolled his eyes, bending over and picking up his backpack from the floor. Kirishima caught the cue and did the same. “You’re both dumb pieces of shit with pigeon crap for brains”.

“Kacchan! Don’t be rude!”, Izuku protested.

“Oi, dude. That’s rude”, Kirishima pointed out.

“For fuck’s sake”, Katsuki groaned, rolling his eyes. “Why did I have to end up with two morons who think alike?”

“Aww, we’re *your* morons!”, Kirishima explained, passing one arm over Katsuki’s shoulders. “Fist bump, Midoriya!”, he announced, stretching his fist in front of his body and waiting

with expectation. Midoriya returned the fist bump, but there was no way Kirishima could know that. He looked at Katsuki with a questioning grin, and Katsuki, who did nothing to shrug off from Kirishima's embrace as he would have done with anyone else, merely rolled his eyes in silence. "Oh, c'mon! Is he fist bumping me back?", Kirishima asked with a stupid grin on his face.

"No", Katsuki lied, a wicked smirk on his lips as they walked out of the gym, still stuck in Kirishima's half-embrace. "He said he refuses to fist bump someone with such an ugly hair".

"Hey! That's not true!", Izuku protested, desperately trying to connect his fist with Kirishima's even though his hand continued to phase on the top of the other boy's. "K-Kirishima-kun! Don't believe him! I don't think your hair is ugly! *Ahhh*! Kacchan, that's really mean!", he protested as he continued to try to fist bump Kirishima without success.

"Ok, I don't believe you", Kirishima simply chuckled. "Midoriya would never say that. Hey, Midoriya, my man, if you can hear me, I know you don't think my hair is ugly!", he reassured, speaking in a loud voice as if Izuku was standing at a great distance.

"He's right beside you, asshole", Katsuki pointed out with an eye-roll. "You don't have to yell".

"Ah, sorry, I couldn't tell", Kirishima said, looking around the hall as if he expected to find Izuku there any moment now.

"It's ok, Kirishima-kun!", Izuku said solemnly, bowing several times.

"It's really weird, you know?", Kirishima pointed out pensively, retrieving his arm from Katsuki's shoulders so that the two of them could walk better. "Knowing he's here, but not being able to see him. I hope they find the villain who did this soon".

"Tell me about it", Katsuki mumbled.

"You must be having a hard time putting up with Bakubro, buddy", Kirishima said, trying to look at Izuku as he spoke but ending up looking at the extreme opposite direction. "Stay strong. We're gonna help you through this".

"Stop talking to the wall, dipshit, he's on your left", Katsuki scoffed. "Also, why does everyone keep saying *he* is the one having a hard time?", he protested angrily.

"Because, as Denki says, you're a nasty explodoboy with the temper of a pissed off feral cat and the manners of a needy puppy dog", Kirishima pointed out, successfully dodging out of the way of Katsuki's hands trying to strangle him for saying that. "Hey! I'm just quoting! It's just a quote! His words, not mine! Ahhh, I'm sorry!", he cried.

"I want to see him say that to my face! I'll kill him!", Katsuki shouted loudly, his hands popping with tiny explosions.

"Okay, okay, I'll have to go now, Bakugou, because if you don't murder me, Aizawa sensei will", Kirishima said, clearly desperate to get away from that situation and taking several

steps back, hands raised in a defensive gesture. “D-Do you want me to tell him anything?”

“Just say I went to the old woman for painkillers and that I’ll be there for class tomorrow”, Katsuki growled, even though he was still very angry. “And *don’t* tell anyone about the punching thing”, he added seriously. “I don’t want anyone hearing about that”.

“All right, all right”, Kirishima said, continuing to take several steps back away from Katsuki as one would do with a feral animal. “Uh, is it okay if I stop by your room later? To see how you’re doing?”, he asked, his cheeks burning slightly at the request. Katsuki stared at him with suspicion. “I mean, it’s just you were talking about pain, and, and shared pain and stuff, and we still haven’t properly talked about what happened because when we were getting there you started hugging Midoriya and stuff –“

“It wasn’t a *hug*, dumbface!”, Katsuki shouted in protest, angry, while Izuku blushed and shook his head frantically (even though Kirishima couldn’t see him).

“Fine, yeah, sorry, you started not-hugging him, anyway, I – I just wanted to talk? You know? See how you’re holding up?”, he offered with a tentative smile and a shrug. “Maybe without having a door slammed on my face this time?”

Katsuki rolled his eyes, annoyed. If he was honest, he didn’t want to talk to anyone about what had happened, but at the same time, Kirishima was the only person so far who actually seemed more concerned for how *he* was holding up in this whole shitty situation, instead of asking about Deku all the time. He obviously cared about Deku too, but he was also the only one who could see how poorly Katsuki was dealing with everything.

“Whatever, Shitty Hair”, Katsuki shrugged, not meeting Kirishima’s eyes. “See if I care”.

“*Kacchan*”, Izuku reprehended.

“Fine, you can stop by or whatever, suit yourself”, he corrected, telling himself that he was only doing this to make Deku get off his case, *only that*. No other reason behind it. Nope. “But if I’m sleeping you better not wake me up, or you’ll get something way worse than a door slammed on your face”, he added with a scoff, just not to lose habit. Izuku sighed, but didn’t protest.

“Okay”, Kirishima raised both hands in defeat, looking actually surprised and pleased that Katsuki had agreed to his request. “I’ll be on my way now, man. See you later?”

“Tch”, was Katsuki’s only response. Shitty Hair waved him goodbye – which he didn’t return, since he had his hands shoved in his pockets – and disappeared at the end of the hallway, heading for class.

Any desire Katsuki may have felt for going back to class died after the accidental shitshow he had pulled earlier. He hadn’t meant to freak out so hard – and now that his theory was proven right, he had a hunch about *why* the freak out session had been so bad.

“So”, he asked Deku as they walked on the opposite direction from Kirishima, heading for the exit of the building and to Recovery Girl’s infirmary. “Since when have you had this?”

“T-This what, Kacchan?”, Deku asked, sounding genuinely clueless. Katsuki scoffed.

“This panicking shit. Anxiety, or whatever the hell you like to call it”, he replied.

“I – I don’t”, Izuku frowned. “I – I d-don’t have anxiety, Kacchan”, he pointed out, sounding concerned.

“Yeah, right”, Katsuki chuckled humorlessly. “Look, shitty Deku, as much as I hate it, and as much as I hate to *say it*, we’re gonna have to be honest with each other from now on. I’m not gonna feel like shit for a week because you’re too much of a lil’ bitch to tell me you’re not feeling good. So you’d better go ahead right now and tell me *everything* that’s bothering you and causing you pain so that I can ask for the old woman for a way to fix it and stop feeling like crap because of *you*”, he instructed.

Izuku was silent for a bit upon Katsuki’s request, pensive. He only spoke up once they stepped out of the building and the warm sun connected with their skins – or rather, Katsuki’s skin. The light just phased through Izuku’s form, making him look more like a ghost than ever.

“Uh, I think my back is what’s bothering the most”, Izuku admitted, not quite looking at Katsuki’s face as he spoke. “Sleeping on the floor is terrible, and it hurts a lot because I’m not really used to it. I haven’t been able to sleep much because of it, which is probably why you’ve been so tired, too”, he pointed out with an apologetic tone in his voice. “I… I think that’s it. I’ll let you know if I think of anything else”, he promised, finally meeting Katsuki’s eyes.

“Yeah, you better do that”, Katsuki scoffed. “Otherwise, I’ll kick your ass”.

“Doesn’t that mean you’ll kick your own ass?”, Izuku asked with a tentative smile.

“Shut your smart mouth”, Katsuki growled. “Damn right I’ll kick my own ass if it means you’ll get dragged down with me”.

“You’re so competitive, Kacchan”, Izuku chuckled.

“Hell yeah”, Katsuki pointed Izuku with an evil smirk. “That’s why I’m gonna surpass you and become number one while your sorry ass struggles to be at least recognized by the media”.

“We’ll see about that”, Izuku replied with a determined look. “I’ll remind you you said this when I become number one”.

“Keep dreaming, Deku”, Katsuki chuckled. “Keep dreaming”.

“Here’s another rule for your shitty notebook, nerd”, Katsuki said. “You paying attention?”

“Always”, Izuku said without thinking. “But you don’t have to say it, Kacchan, I think you made it pretty clear –“

“Shut up. It’s my turn to talk”, Katsuki interrupted, pointing at the pile of pillows carefully placed in the middle of his bed. “Since the old woman said you need to sleep on an actual bed so that none of us gets fucking backpains like a pair of old-ass losers, I am mercifully allowing you to sleep on my bed, since I know it’s fucking amazing”, he announced.

“Wow”, Izuku said in a deadpan, unimpressed. “Thanks, Kacchan”, he added sarcastically.

“You keep that fucking attitude up and I’ll shove your bony ass back into that floor, no matter how bad it hurts my back”, Katsuki threatened. He picked up two of the pills that Recovery Girl had given him and dry swallowed them. They were supposed to help with the pain and relax his muscles, with the possible side effect of making him groggy and sleepy.

“Fine, fine, go on”, Izuku chuckled, rolling his eyes. “What’s the rule?”

“The rule is that you don’t fucking cross the pillow fort”, Katsuki said, continuing to point at the pile of pillows. “You cross the pillow fort limit, I blow your soul up so hard you’ll end up back inside your body. You touch me while I sleep, I blow your soul up *so hard* the pieces *won’t be able* to find your body. You stare at me while I sleep or as much as breathe next to me – well, I guess you already know what happens”.

“You blow me up in some gruesome, graphic way”, Izuku sighed tiredly.

“Damn right I do”, Katsuki said, plopping down on his side of the bed and lying down with his legs crossed. He placed his hands beneath his head and stared up at the ceiling. “That side is yours. This side is mine. Don’t even dream about sleeping on my side, or I’ll blow you up. We clear?”

“Yes, Kacchan”, Izuku said, removing his ridiculous red shoes and laying down on the bed next to Kacchan. The pillow fort the boy had built contained so many pillows and was so tall that Izuku couldn’t see his face unless he sat or stood up. For some reason, Izuku felt more comfortable that way. It was probably the closest thing to privacy they could get, after closed doors in a close range.

Izuku sighed in relief. Kacchan’s bed really was amazing. He had only lied down on it for a few moments, but his back already felt way greater. He ended up relaxing, staring up at the ceiling and allowing his thoughts to wander. The room was silent and there were birds chirping outside, but the noise was pleasant. The light from the late morning was entering Kacchan’s room through thin streaks that managed to bypass the closed curtains. It felt like an eternity before Izuku broke the peace in the room.

“So, we’re going to take a nap now?”, he asked quietly. Katsuki sighed.

“I was almost managing to get one, but you *had* to interrupt me, didn’t you”, he growled. “*Yes*, we are getting a nap. The pills Recovery Girl gave me made me fucking sleepy, and I won’t be able to do much myself until your crappy back gets better”.

“Huh”, Izuku mumbled with curiosity.

“Huh *what*? What is it?”, Katsuki growled again, sounding exponentially annoyed.

“You didn’t call her ‘old woman’ this time”, Izuku commented absentmindedly. From his isolated side of the bed, he couldn’t see Katsuki’s reaction.

“That’s because she gave me good pills that make my back stop fucking hurting, something you’re failing to do”, Katsuki replied bitterly. “Just shut the hell up and go to sleep. I need your back to get better so that *mine* can get better, so start working on that and count sheep or some shit”.

“But it feels wrong, you know? It’s not even lunch time yet, and we’re… just sleeping”.

“I sure as fuck am not sleeping right now. Who’s to blame for that, huh?”

“Sorry. I just… can’t help thinking about some stuff”.

“Then think in silence. I’m trying to take a fucking nap so I can stop walking around like a pathetic slug”.

A pause.

“Why do you think I’m wearing these clothes?”

“Deku, I swear to fucking *god* –“

“No, I mean it. I should be in a hospital gown, right? Or at least in my hero costume. It makes no sense that I’m wearing these regular clothes when I wasn’t anywhere near them at the time I – … Well”.

Silence.

“Yeah. That’s really weird”.

“I was thinking that maybe it has to do with emotional attachment, because my mom gave me this shirt and All Might gave me these pants and, well, I don’t have to say anything about the shoes, do I?”

“What about the shoes?”

Silence.

“You’re a piece of shit”.

"*What*? Why?!"

"You already started talking, so tell what the fuck it is about the damn shoes or leave me the fuck alone already".

"You – don't remember?"

"Do I sound like I fucking remember?"

"You gave them to me. Or – well. Your mom gave them to me when she came over to talk to my mom. She said you had bought them to me. As a late birthday gift. They're just like the ones I used to wear when we were kids, but I outgrew them and mom couldn't really afford new ones".

Silence.

"That's lame".

"Hm?"

"I don't remember that".

"Clearly".

"Don't get fucking sassy with me".

"Sorry. But yeah. I still don't know why I'm wearing these clothes".

"It doesn't really matter, does it? Better than having you walk around naked".

"I suppose… Still, I found it a bit curious".

"There are lots of curious things about this whole shitshow, Deku. I don't think your fucking clothes are the creepiest part".

"You're right, I guess".

"I'm always fucking right".

Silence.

Silence.

More silence.

"Why are you emotionally attached to the shoes?"

"Huh?"

"You said you think you're wearing these clothes because of emotional attachment. Then why the fuck are you attached to the shoes?"

A pause.

“Because Kacchan gave them to me”.

A scoff.

“That wasn’t me, asshole. That was my *mom*. Are you saying you’re emotionally attached to my mom?”

“N-No… But she said it had been you. I believed her”.

“Why the fuck would you believe her? That was clearly a lie, Deku. Why the hell would I bother giving you a birthday gift, let alone a pair of expensive shoes? I could barely tolerate you”.

“Oh. Well… I don’t know”.

Another scoff.

“I guess I wanted to believe it?”

“That’s pathetic”.

“Yeah. I know”.

Silence.

“I suppose it was considerate of her, though. To get me a birthday gift”.

“It was ridiculous”.

“It was nice. I like them”.

“Clearly. You never wear anything else”.

“Because they’re great! They’re comfortable and they look good –“

“I bet they smell”.

“They don’t smell!”

“They can’t *not* smell. You wear them all the time. Of course they smell”.

“They don’t smell! Stop saying that!”.

“Smelly feet”.

“I think the pills Recovery Girl gave you are turning your brains into mush”.

“Then they’re turning your brains into mush, too. We’re in this shit together”.

“Yeah. I do feel kind of tipsy”.

“You’re pathetic”.

“Stop saying that. It’s rude”.

“It’s the truth”.

“I may have been pathetic once, but I’m not anymore. I’m getting stronger”.

“Not with those smelly feet, you aren’t”.

“Stop saying my feet are smelly! You haven’t even smelt them!”

“I’ll be damned if I plan to”.

“Then stop!”

“Fucking make me”.

“God, those must be some really good drugs”.

“If they were good, I’d be asleep by now, instead of listening to your crap”.

“Sorry. I’ll let you sleep now”.

“Fucking finally”.

Silence.

Silence.

Silence.

“I think it’s nice when you’re nice to people”.

“I swear to god, I am going to murder the *hell* out of you”.

“I think you hurt Kirishima-kun’s feelings today, even if he played it off. I think the things you told him hurt him, even though you were just trying to provoke him”.

“I don’t remember asking for your fucking opinion”.

“He cares about you. He’s your friend”.

“Here comes the fucking friendship expert again. You’d better shut the hell up before you regret it”.

“I’m just saying it because I know you care for him, too. You should probably apologize”.

“Like *hell*. Honestly, heart-to-heart is over. Mind your damn business and go the hell to sleep. Or don’t – just stop talking and leave me the hell alone”.

“Why do you find it so hard to just *be nice*? I know you can be!”

Silence.

“You used to be”.

“What, when we were four? Fuck off”.

More silence.

“I just… I want to help you, Kacchan”.

“Who says I need your shitty help, asshole?!”

“Not needing help doesn’t mean you can’t get it anyway”.

“Let me know how much this unwanted little therapy session will cost me when you’re done. I’m gonna go to sleep now”.

“Just apologize to Kirishima-kun! It will be good for him! And… for you, too”.

“Apologize for *what*? I didn’t do anything wrong”.

“You said mean things about him not being your friend. I could tell how much it hurt him”.

“He’s tough. His power is literally to *resist things*. I don’t need to apologize for shit, he knows how I am and he’s willing to take it”.

“But why should he? Why can’t you just be nice?”

“Because I’m not fucking *nice*. I’m strong, and I’m tough, and I’m fucking awesome, but I ain’t nice. And I’m not gonna be just because your touchy feelings get upset every time I yell at you. Don’t like it, go haunt someone else. Otherwise, deal with it”.

Silence.

“Okay”.

“Good. Now shut the hell up before I rip your tongue off”.

“Good night, Kacchan”.

“It’s not even noon yet, dipshit”.

“Uh… Sleep well, then?”

“Tch”.

From: Bakubro

Listen asshole

From: Bakubro

I was just trying to rile you up

From: Bakubro

So that you'd punch me in the face

From: Bakubro

No need to get all touchy feely about this shit ok

From: Bakubro

You're my friend and all that cheesy crap you like to say

From: Bakubro

I was just provoking you so don't read too much into it

From: Shitty Hair

??????????

From: Shitty Hair

Nani????

From: Shitty Hair

Wait, did Midoriya tell you to apologize

From: Shitty Hair

Is that what this is about

From: Shitty Hair

Because that's really sweet bro

From: Bakubro

You're so embarrassing

From: Shitty Hair

Aww you're growing

From: Shitty Hair

Like a blooming bakuflower

From: Bakubro

I'll murder you and your entire family

From: Shitty Hair

Whoop there he is

From: Bakubro

Don't know why I even bothered

From: Bakubro

Bye

From: Shitty Hair

Bro we talked about just sayin "bye"

From: Shitty Hair

I never know if it's passive aggressive or not

From: Shitty Hair

Are you actually leaving

From: Shitty Hair

Bakubro?????

From: Bakubro

Stop calling me that

From: Shitty Hair

Ahh so you weren't leaving

From: Shitty Hair

See, I can never tell

From: Bakubro

I was leaving, your stupidity made me come back

From: Shitty Hair

Rude

From: Shitty Hair

But really

From: Shitty Hair

Thanks for apologizing??

From: Shitty Hair

It means a lot

From: Shitty Hair

You're the best bro

From: Bakubro

I already know that

From: Shitty Hair

Tell midori we miss himmmmm

From: Bakubro

Tell him yourself

From: Bakubro

Bye

From: Shitty Hair

Are you leaving for real now?

From: Shitty Hair

Hey

From: Shitty Hair

Bakubro?????

From: Shitty Hair

Oh dang

From: Shitty Hair

Well at least you're polite enough to say 'bye' I guess

From: Shitty Hair

I'll stop by later!!

Katsuki put his phone away and went to sleep, the painkillers preventing him from dwelling too much on what had happened throughout that day and why there was a tight feeling inside his chest that didn't seem to be just a mirror of Deku's feelings.

Chapter End Notes

I've been experimenting a bit with my narrative style, so I hope this turned out ok!
Will these boys ever just... you know..... *talk* about feelings
I just love Kirishima way too much and he deserves all the happiness in the world. Also, I'm in love with Izuku trying to help grumpy Bakubro to be less grumpy!! The rest of Class 1-A will show up more often, I swear!!
Sorry for taking so long to post this, and I hope you guys enjoy this chapter! Happy Holidays for everyone who celebrates them!

Chapter 6: Spicy Katsudon and Bitter Tea

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Katsuki woke up feeling incredibly well-rested, even though his tongue was slightly dry from dehydration and his head felt a bit mushy still. He couldn't tell if the feeling had to do with the medicine he had taken or with the prolonged sleep. Either way, he decided to open his eyes and ready himself to get up – every unnecessary moment he spent on his bed was wasting time he could use to train and get stronger.

His lids parted and the first thing he saw was a pile of pillows right in front of him. One of his arms had crossed the limit established by the pillow fort and the tips of his fingers were brushing something ticklish and soft. Katsuki realized with horror that this something his hand was touching was Deku's hair, and withdrew it as quickly as he could, memories about what had happened flooding his head. Fuck. He had almost forgotten about shitty Deku getting his soul stuck to his, about the shared pain shit, and about the sharing-a-bed shit (which he convinced himself was the worst part).

Peeking over the pillow fort and doing his best to hide his embarrassment about having been the one to break the no-trespassing rule instead of Deku, Katsuki saw the boy was still fast asleep, unaware of Katsuki's accidental touch. Izuku was lying on a fetal position as close as possible to the edge of the bed, as if he was trying his best to stay as far away from Katsuki as he could. With a huff and an annoyed "Tch", Katsuki sat up on the bed and rubbed at his eyes, thankful that they didn't need each other to be asleep in order to get some rest. At least, something.

He had been so exhausted when he built the pillow fort that he didn't consider the fact that Deku didn't need to use the bathroom, but he did. And he had stupidly chosen the wrong side of the pillow fort to sleep on – his side was where the mattress met the wall, meaning he would either have to slide himself all the way to the foot of the bed in order to get out or just hop over Deku while the boy slept.

Katsuki decided sliding to the foot of the bed was too risky – he would certainly end up making the mattress rattle and possibly wake Deku up. He didn't give a shit about disrupting the boy's sleep – if they had been in any other situation, he might have actually put an effort into purposefully waking Deku up. The problem at hands were: 1. Deku needed rest in order for Katsuki not to feel like shit all the time, so waking him up wasn't best case scenario; 2. Being stuck with a rambling Deku all the time was annoying as hell and Katsuki wasn't about to throw away one of his rare shots at having some private time for himself. While Deku was asleep he could finally have some peace and privacy, even if it wouldn't last as long as he wished, so waking him up was equivalent to jeopardizing his only shot at that.

Fine. No rattling the mattress, then.

God, he fucking hated this. He couldn't even get out of his own bed without having to worry about it. He wished Deku would get out of his case already.

Katsuki carefully removed the pillows separating his side from Deku's side, so that he would manage to pass above the boy more easily. Izuku continued to sleep like a deadweight, probably exhausted by the past days and everything that had happened. Katsuki found himself staring at the way Deku's mouth was slack and open, soft little snores escaping every other breath. He looked so relaxed and his expression was so plain that, if it hadn't been for the soft rise and fall of his chest, Katsuki might have thought he was – he was –

His heartrate picked up for some reason at the thought. Memories of dead eyes and limp limbs flooded his brain and made Katsuki's hands tighten into fists, his body entering fight-or-flight mode even though there was no threat there in the dark bedroom. He hated this – these sudden spikes of fear and adrenaline that came accompanied by confusing flashes of memory, things he couldn't make sense of, things he couldn't comprehend. He had his suspicions about what those flashes were, but thinking about the possible reasons behind them made him angry and confused.

Kirishima said he had freaked out when he thought Deku was dead. Katsuki knew it in his heart that couldn't be true – he barely tolerated the brat on his best days, and hated him on his most. There was no way he would lose it if he thought the shitty nerd had died.

But then, why did the sight of dead, half-lidded, green eyes and an emotionless expression on that freckled face made his chest tighten so hard and his lungs lose all breath?

God, he was losing time. He didn't want to think about that. He didn't give a shit about that. He couldn't give a shit. He didn't have to. Fuck. He was losing focus. Feeling angry even though there was no actual reason to, Katsuki got rid of the last pillow that made the fort and carefully positioned himself above Deku so that he could get out of the bed without moving it too much.

He positioned each of his hands on each side of Deku, doing the same with his knees. This way, he was on all fours above the sleeping boy, his arms and legs spread so that he didn't touch Deku. He was on the process of carefully raising his right arm and right knee in order to finally hop off the bed when Deku's eyes blinked open, unfocused and sluggish, probably still more asleep than awake.

"Kacchan", he sighed, voice hoarse and low, looking exhausted. Katsuki froze.

"You're dreaming", was all he could think to say, because convincing the stupid fucking nerd that Katsuki being on all fours above him was nothing more than a dream was way easier and less embarrassing than explaining why it had actually happened. "Close your eyes", he added, desperate for Deku to sleep again before he could regain full consciousness.

"'Kay", was Izuku's sleepy response, right before he shut his eyes obediently and sighed contently. "Bye, Kacchan".

Katsuki waited for a few moments to make sure Izuku was back to sleep before finally resuming his arduous task of getting out of bed. He carefully positioned both his knees on Izuku's left side and triumphantly stood up, letting out a shaky breath of relief. If the nerd questioned him about what had happened later when he woke up, Katsuki could always argue

that it had been just his stupid imagination making things up. Either way, he would make shitty Deku take the other side of the bed next time.

He went to the bathroom to attend to nature's call and grabbed a bottle of water from his minifridge on the way back. Shitty Hair would probably stop by any second now and Katsuki would be damned if he allowed himself to be caught in bed with shitty Deku, of all people. He trusted Kirishima with his life at this point, but he also knew the boy well enough to know he wouldn't be able to keep something like that as a secret.

Just as Katsuki had imagined, it didn't take too long for a soft knock on his bedroom door to call his attention. He stood up from where he had been sitting by his studying desk and opened the door quietly, still careful not to wake Deku up. Ideally, it would be better for him and Kirishima to talk on the hall – this way, Deku would continue to sleep and wouldn't be able to eavesdrop their conversation in case he woke up. However, if they did talk on the hall, one of his shitty friends was bound to eavesdrop. Katsuki decided to silently nod at Kirishima, indicating that he could enter his bedroom. He was one of the only people Katsuki had ever allowed in.

"So, Bakubro, are you gonna tell me what –", Kirishima started to speak in a very loud voice, which made Katsuki shush him violently as he closed the door behind him with a click. Kirishima frowned in confusion, unaware of the sleeping Izuku on Katsuki's bed, and Katsuki slowly made his way to him in order to explain in a very low tone.

"Shut the fuck up and don't be so fucking loud", he whispered, nodding at the bed. Kirishima followed his gaze, but continued to look as confused as before, since he could see nothing. Katsuki's friend looked like he was about to burst with hundreds of questions, but managed to stay obediently silent, for once.

Izuku had shifted positions in his sleep at Kirishima's noisy voice – now, he was lying on his back, his mouth wide open with one streak of saliva rolling down his cheek and one of his arms dangling off the mattress, his hand almost touching the floor. There was no way that position was comfortable and the last thing Katsuki needed was a sore shoulder, so with a sigh and an eyeroll, he grabbed Izuku's arm and carefully placed it on the top of the boy's chest. Izuku sighed contently again and hummed low on his throat, shifting again and lying on his side, his back turned to Katsuki and Kirishima. Apparently, the stupid nerd moved a lot in his sleep.

When Katsuki turned to face Kirishima, he found wide eyes and a smug expression on his friend's face, as if he knew a secret that Katsuki didn't. Rolling his eyes again – this time, with a considerably grimmer expression than before – he grabbed Kirishima by the elbow and dragged him to the farthest corner of his room, so that they could speak in a low voice without risking waking the shitty nerd up. Kirishima followed obediently, allowing Katsuki to drag him along when he sat down on the floor, his back leaning on the wall behind him. They were both sitting by the bedroom door, now – the highest distance Katsuki could get from Izuku without inevitably dragging him along.

Before Shitty Hair could even open his mouth to speak, Katsuki started, meaning to end this as quickly as he could. It was bad enough to be stuck with Deku all the time – the last thing he wanted was to talk about it, on the top of having to deal with it. However, he knew he

owed Kirishima at least some explanations – for example, he didn't want his friend to think that he had let Deku into his bed out of anything other than their mutual need for rest.

"Imma say what you want to know and you'll shut up and listen, got it?", Katsuki said, voice barely above a whisper as if not to disrupt Deku. Kirishima gazed at him with wide, curious eyes, but nodded his head. "If you have any questions, shove them up your ass. You interrupt me, I'll kick you out", he added. Kirishima looked less happy at this, but sighed and nodded again.

Katsuki huffed out an annoyed breath and leaned his forearms on his knees bent in front of him, supporting his head on the wall behind him. He stared off at the distance when he begun to speak.

"From what we know so far, the villain's quirk removed Deku's soul from his body and bound it to my soul. No one has any idea how it fucking works, so if you plan on asking me about that, don't. All I know is that the reason why I'm the only one who can see, talk, and touch him is because his soul is bound to mine, and until we find the asshole who did this, I can't get 50 feet away from him without dragging him along. It's like there's an invisible cord tying us together or some shit. I can't even take a shit without having this asshole wait for me at the door".

Kirishima looked shocked at this and, from the way his lips looked wobbly out of a sudden, Katsuki suspected he was holding back a laugh. Getting angrier at this, he bared his teeth, which caused the expected result and had Kirishima bow his head in a silent apology.

"Anyway. I've been feeling like shit these past days because, apparently, I can feel Deku's feelings, too. I started to suspect this yesterday, which was why I asked you to punch me earlier. This fucking sucks, because he's a crybaby and a loser who gets upset over everything, and, for all the annoying-ass mumbling he's constantly doing, he never says the important stuff. He's been sleeping on the floor ever since we got stuck together, which has been fucking with his back and, as a result, has been fucking with my back. That's why he's on the bed now. And why we're not gonna wake him up", he concluded with another annoyed huff. This time, Kirishima smiled.

"Aw, Bakugou. I almost thought you cared!", he commented with humor in an equally low voice, but Katsuki could identify the teasing behind his words. He glared at his friend and snarled.

"I don't give a shit about him, ok?", he said, sounding a bit too defensive. "I just need him to be rested and not in pain so that I can be rested and not in fucking pain. This isn't some sentimental bullshit or whatever it is you're thinking. I just need him to be ok so that I can be ok, too".

"You do know that sounded sweeter than you intended, right?", Kirishima raised his eyebrows playfully. It took all of Katsuki's self-control to prevent his fisted palms from popping with loud, angry explosions.

"Shut the fuck up", Katsuki growled with annoyance. Deku shifted on the bed again, turning so that he was facing Katsuki and Kirishima. He was still fast asleep. "I'm not fucking sweet.

Now, if that's all you wanted to know, you can piss the fuck off and get out of my room", he added, readying himself to get up and go back to his feet.

"Hey", Kirishima grabbed one his arms before he managed to get up, looking slightly worried and hurt. His voice was still low, but he sounded like he was having a hard time controlling the volume. "That wasn't all I wanted to know, man", he pulled Katsuki back so that he was sitting down again. "I mean, how are you? With everything that's happening? How's your head?"

"It's fine", Katsuki scoffed, not meeting Kirishima's eyes. "I'm ok. Just pissed as fuck about this being-stuck-with-Deku shit. I just want to get rid of him already".

"Yeah, I can imagine that", Kirishima nodded solemnly. "Of all the people you could have ended up stuck with, it had to be him, hadn't it?"

"Just my fucking luck", Katsuki shook his head slightly. "I just want to get my privacy back, you know? But Aizawa sensei and the fucking principal keep telling me to stay out of it and let them handle it. That's probably because they're not the ones who have a fucking nerd glued to their ass mumbling in their ear 24/7. Now I can't even fucking punch Deku for not shutting up without feeling the hit, too. This fucking sucks", he vented. Kirishima was possibly one of the only people Katsuki felt like he could vent to without feeling like a loser about it.

"I think this time you should let them handle it, bro", Kirishima suggested, shrugging. "I mean, if no one's sure of what the villain's quirk can do, it wouldn't be safe for you to go after him on your own. Especially after what happened".

Katsuki snapped his head to look at Kirishima, a furious, indignant glare on his crimson eyes.

"The fuck do you mean by that, Shitty Hair?", he asked, offended. Kirishima raised his hands in defeat, trying to indicate he had meant no harm with his words.

"I'm just saying that guy could have killed you, man. He almost killed Midoriya. I – I know you probably don't feel the need to go to the medical bay because you can see him all the time, but… He's not looking so good, Bakugou", he added almost grimly, a worried look on his face. Katsuki frowned. "I don't know what he's looking like to you, but the Midoriya who's back there, lying in bed... He looks more dead than alive".

"That's fucking expectable since his soul is literally not in his body", Katsuki pointed out as if Kirishima was stupid, frowning. Why did those words bothered him so much?

Why did the image of a dead Deku bother him so much?

Katsuki ended up wondering if Deku's eyes were open back where he was lying on the infirmary and he shivered, shaking the thought off his head.

"But it's different", Kirishima shrugged, looking disturbed. "I mean, he's not dead… And we know you can see him, you know? He's sort of… still around, even if we can't see him. But when I went there to visit him yesterday, I don't know… It felt like he wasn't going to wake

up", he concluded, not meeting Katsuki's eyes. For some reason, those words pissed him off harder than anything Kirishima had said so far.

"Get the fuck away from me with that bullshit", he growled. "Of course he's fucking waking up. You think I'm gonna spend the rest of my life having shitty Deku glued to me? If they don't find a way to shove his soul back to his body, I'll do it myself".

"It's not that, man", Kirishima shook his head again. Katsuki didn't like the way his friend was looking so sad all of a sudden. "I mean, what if he doesn't wake up and he – you, you know. What if he just… dies?"

Katsuki squinted his eyes at Kirishima, suspicion etched all over his face. When the boy said nothing else, he leaned towards him.

"Talk", he instructed sharply. Kirishima met his burning gaze quickly before averting his eyes.

"I mean, I don't think it's doing wonders to his body to have his soul away from it for so long", Kirishima shrugged. "This was just something we and the guys have been discussing. He's looking worse with each passing day, Recovery Girl says his charts have been acting crazy, and… This is just – unnatural, you know? I don't know how this whole soul thing works, I don't think any of us do, but it isn't supposed to be like this. It – it isn't supposed to be disconnected from his body, or connected to you. I mean – don't you feel like this is wrong? Feeling his pain and… well", he trailed off, sounding like he didn't want to continue. Katsuki stared at him.

"Go on", he encouraged, managing to not sound so angry. Kirishima eyed him hesitantly.

"You're not looking so great, either", Kirishima continued, sounding concerned. "I don't know when you last looked at yourself in a mirror, but don't seem to be doing so great, man. I'm worried about you – we, we all are worried about you", he pointed out, but Katsuki scoffed. "I'm – just saying this because Tokoyami pointed something out yesterday during lunch and it made me even more worried", he continued, making Katsuki frown.

"What did bird-brain say?", he asked. Kirishima hesitated again, but didn't wait for Katsuki's encouragement to continue.

"He said he thinks Midoriya is – well", he sighed. "He thinks Midoriya is consuming your lifeforce. In the sense that your body has two souls attached to it, when it should have only one. It's overloading you".

Katsuki continued to stare silently.

"I mean, you do look tired –", Kirishima tried to continue after a while , but Katsuki interrupted him.

"I'm fine", he said simply.

"Bakugou –"

“I said I’m fine”, he repeated. He didn’t know why he felt the need to defend himself so vehemently from Kirishima’s accusation, but he just did. “I’m not overloaded. I told you – I was just feeling like shit because I didn’t know me and Deku were sharing pain. Now that I know that, I can make sure it won’t happen again. Which is why I have the shitty nerd on the bed right now”, he pointed out. Kirishima gave him an almost sad look, but decided not to argue.

“Well, I hope you’re right”, he shrugged.

“When am I not fucking right?”, Katsuki raised an indignant eyebrow at his friend, earning a small smile from him.

“Yeah, yeah”, he admitted, slumping his shoulders in defeat. “Ok”.

They fell into an uneasy silence after that, the two friends sitting together on the floor, their backs leaning on the wall behind them. Kirishima was idly tapping his fingers on a notebook sitting on his lap, while Bakugou had his forearms leaning on his knees while he stared straight ahead in deep thought.

Bird-brain’s theory didn’t make any sense, because now that Deku was sleeping on a bed, now that he was well-rested and not in pain anymore, Katsuki felt great. The nap he had just taken had revigorated him, he was feeling more like himself than he had in the past three days, and he didn’t feel tired at all. Having Deku’s soul attached to his was annoying as fuck, but not because it was drawing out his lifeforce or some shit. It was annoying because it was Deku glued to Katsuki.

What, his shitty friends thought he couldn’t take it? They thought he was a weak-ass loser who couldn’t handle Deku for a few days without becoming weak? Fuck them. Katsuki would prove them wrong. He would prove them all fucking wrong. Maybe the shitshow that had been his return to class encouraged them to think Katsuki wasn’t coping well, but he’d show them. He’d show them just how well he could handle this whole thing without breaking. He wouldn’t break.

He would return to class. He would become top of his class. He would show them he had all the means to be the best, even with the extra weight of Deku’s shitty soul attached to him.

And, as soon as he had the chance to slam dunk Deku’s annoying-ass ghost back into his pathetic little body, Katsuki would do just that. Not because he couldn’t take the extra weight, but because Katsuki couldn’t stand him. Only that. He couldn’t stand Deku.

It was easier to believe that. It was simpler. If he just believed the mixed, confusing feelings that bubbled up inside his chest every time he thought about Deku consisted of anger, and only anger, his life became 100% easier.

(It really didn’t, though, but Katsuki didn’t like thinking about it).

Kirishima knew better than to insist in that subject which was clearly annoying his friend, so instead he simply grabbed the notebook he had been tapping on and handed it over to Katsuki

after a few moments of silence, offering him another small smile. Katsuki took the notebook with a confused angry look, waiting for an explanation.

“I’ve been taking notes for you”, Kirishima explained. Katsuki vaguely remembered hearing Round Face say something about that during his panic attack back at the classroom. “You only lost a few days of class, but knowing you, I’m assuming you don’t want to fall behind. I – I did ask Yao-Momo for help, so don’t worry, the notes aren’t just mine”, he added. Katsuki felt something warm in his chest at Kirishima’s words, but continued to stare at him with a straight face.

“Thank god”, he commented, a playful, evil smirk blossoming on his lips. “If it had been just your shitty notes, I would have probably ended up as the last of our class”, he teased. Kirishima looked slightly hurt for a split second, but as soon as he noticed the teasing edge in Katsuki’s tone, he grinned and playfully shoved him away.

“You’re an asshole”, he said, chuckling as lowly as he could as if not to wake Izuku up.

“And you still can’t get enough of me”, Katsuki shrugged with a smug look on his face. Kirishima knew that was his way of saying thank you – not only for the notes, but for worrying about him. Katsuki felt like he was the only one who did.

“But really, man”, Kirishima added, a bit more seriously but still smiling. “If you need anything – if, if you feel anything – just talk to me, ok? It’s ok to feel bad in the situation you’re in”.

“Don’t ruin the fucking moment, Hair-For-Brains”, Katsuki rolled his eyes in annoyance, leaning his hands on the floor in order to get to his feet. Kirishima wasn’t fast enough to stop him this time and, once he was up, Katsuki offered him a hand to help him get up as well. Kirishima took his hand and was on his feet in the matter of seconds. “I told you, I’m ok. As long as the shitty nerd isn’t tired or in pain, I’ll be fine. All I gotta do is stop punching him and shoving him around. It’s gonna be difficult, but not impossible”, he concluded, placing the notebook Kirishima had handed him on his studying desk.

“But really, man”, Kirishima insisted. “If there’s anything I can do –“

“There’s actually something you can do”, Katsuki interrupted and crossed his arms above his chest, giving Kirishima an annoyed look. “Tell your shitty friends to stop crowding me and asking me a hundred fucking questions at the same time. I can barely stand them on a good day, and all the crowding makes Deku anxious. That’s why I freaked out today – all the shitty nerd’s anxiety ended up being inside me”, he admitted, not meeting Kirishima’s eyes, even though there was still a glare on his face.

“Oh”, Kirishima exclaimed simply, as if the thought hadn’t occurred to him. “Oh, ok. I’ll tell them to give you space”, he nodded solemnly.

“Tell them to stay the fuck away from me unless they have something useful to say”, Katsuki corrected, earning an eyeroll from Kirishima. “Now get the hell out of here. I have to study for tomorrow”, he walked over to the door so that he could open it for Kirishima.

“You’re going to class tomorrow?”, Kirishima asked, looking surprised. Katsuki sighed.

“Yeah, of course I am. I already missed enough fucking classes”, he said, twisting the doorknob and pulling the door open. The light from the hallway flooded the otherwise dark room and Izuku instinctively buried his eyes on the crook of his arm, still fast asleep on the bed.

“Alright”, Kirishima agreed, walking out of the bedroom but lingering by the doorframe. “Hey, and if there’s anything you need –“

“I know”, Katsuki interrupted.

“I’m serious, man”, Kirishima insisted. “Just text me, ok?”

“Fine, Kirishima”, Katsuki rolled his eyes, sighing. Kirishima’s face lit up in joy upon the use of his actual name, but before he managed to ruin the moment again, or before he could spot Katsuki’s face blushing in embarrassment for the accidental slip, the explosive boy shut the door silently on his friend’s face. His desire had been to slam it like he had done the other day, but the longest Deku slept, the more time he would have for himself. Kirishima had enough decency not to knock again.

Katsuki made his way back to his studying desk, sitting by it and pulling his curtain slightly open just so that a streak of light would make its way in and illuminate the notebook enough for him to read it. Since it was late afternoon, Katsuki knew the daylight wouldn’t last for long. He would have to turn his lamp on in a while, but that would be a problem for later.

Sighing, he opened his drawer and fished out his pair of reading glasses – he only ever wore them when he studied in his bedroom, since it made him more comfortable and helped him concentrate. Once he adjusted the glasses on the bridge of his nose, he opened Kirishima’s notebook and gave the notes an overview, just so that he would know what he was dealing with before he got started. He could easily differ between Kirishima’s and Yaoyorozu’s notes – the former’s were messy, quick and often too general, while the latter’s were neat, concise and straight to the point. Still, Katsuki couldn’t say he wasn’t thankful to both of them for taking the time to make the annotations for him. Not that he would ever express his gratitude out loud.

His phone pinged with a new text, which reminded him to set the device on silent mode. Grabbing it, he found the text to be from Kirishima, and rolled his eyes in annoyance.

From: Shitty Hair

You called me Kirishima!!!!!!!

From: Bakubro:

Stop making it fucking weird

From: Shitty Hair

Sorry

From: Shitty Hair

But really

From: Shitty Hair

If you want to you can call me Kirishima

From: Shitty Hair

Or Eijirou

From: Shitty Hair

Whatever suits you

From: Bakubro

Ok Shitty Hair

From: Shitty Hair

Noooooo

From: Shitty Hair

What about your progressssssss

From: Bakubro

Let me fucking study

From: Shitty Hair

Ok Bakubro

From: Shitty Hair

Text me if you need anything!!

From: Bakubro

Ok Shitty Hair

From: Shitty Hair

:-/

Everything was pleasant and warm and fuzzy and wonderful, until it wasn't.

He dreamt of his mom's soft, gentle hands running through his hair, his curls, caressing them in the way she knew he loved and making him feel safe, protected, good, and then it was All Might, not his mom, pulling him into a tight embrace and telling him he was proud, he had made it, he could be a hero, he could carry his legacy. Uraraka and Iida had been there too, chatting with him in the grassy floor of UA's garden, which looked so pretty in the spring, with the petals from sakura flowers floating in the air and dropping at their feet, the sun streak warm on their faces and making Uraraka's cheery face look even prettier. Iida's glasses became bright and white from the sun, and Izuku asked him why he didn't take them off, only while they were in the brightness, only for a moment. Todoroki came over later, Tsu following close behind him with Kirishima, Kaminari, Yao-Momo and Mina. They all sat together on the grass and had a great time, chatting and laughing and having fun. Izuku had never felt more loved – after spending his whole life without friends, only being mocked and shoved and bullied, it sure felt wonderful to feel loved for once.

Then Todoroki asked him to wake up, and Tsu said she believed in him, and Uraraka cried and cried and cried, her sobs mingling with his mom's until All Might said they should let him rest and Uraraka protested saying he was in a coma, what more rest could he need? Iida pointed out that she shouldn't talk back to a teacher and she cried harder, but in a moment, they were gone, and Izuku was all alone in the grassy garden, the sun still shining brightly and making the scars on his right arm stand out. He felt lonely, but he couldn't move, and instead he simply lay there, waiting for his friends to return, waiting for his mom to talk to him again. He missed her voice, he missed her touch, he missed her motherly gaze and her gentle hand running through his curls affectionately, he missed her so bad, he just wanted to see her for a bit and tell her he was sorry for making her worry so much, he didn't mean to, it wasn't his fault…

He woke up with a jolt, his loud gasp breaking the silence in the room. It took his sleep-addled brain longer than it should to make sense of his surroundings, but once he realized he was in Katsuki's room, he allowed himself to fall back on the bed, closing his eyes and attempting to ease down his rushed breathing. Once his chest was rising and falling at a normal speed, Izuku reopened his eyes, searching for Kacchan.

He found the boy to be sitting right beside him, by his studying desk. He was leaning over two notebooks, reading one and taking notes on the other. He didn't turn to look at Izuku and, if it hadn't been for his next words, Izuku wouldn't have known if Kacchan was even aware he was awake.

"You had a nightmare or some shit?", Katsuki asked, never ceasing to take notes or turning to look at him. Izuku swallowed dry, not knowing how to respond. Surely, he woke up in a

fright, but he didn't have a nightmare. In fact, his dreams had been perfectly pleasant so far, but he guessed being alone was what resulted on his panic.

Of course, he was used to being alone. He had been alone for his entire life. But still, his mom was the one person who had always been there for him. When the entire world rejected him for being quirkless, his mom had been the only one to be there for him, even if had been to hug him and apologize.

In the dream, she disappeared, along with all of Izuku's friends. She hadn't been there. All the people who he had grown to love – Uraraka, Iida, Todoroki, his friends, all of them – had disappeared. He had been entirely, utterly alone – and he found there was nothing in the world that terrified him most, at least in that moment.

Izuku tried to imagine himself telling Kacchan that – explaining that he had a perfectly pleasant dream that ended with him being all alone. Explaining that was the reason behind his abrupt awakening. Explaining he was afraid. Explaining that, even if Kacchan was constantly by his side, constantly yelling at him, he still felt almost as lonely as he had felt his entire life. He wanted to explain he missed his friends, he missed All Might, and, most of all, he missed his mom. He wanted to explain that his chest ached every time he thought about her, every time he pictured her crying by his hospital bedside.

He tried to imagine Kacchan's response. None of the possibilities that crossed his mind were pleasant.

There was no use opening up about his feelings. He was already feeling bad enough on his own – he didn't need Kacchan to call him a pathetic loser or a crybaby on the top of everything else. He decided to change the subject.

"You're wearing glasses", Izuku replied obviously after a few moments in silence. Katsuki set his pencil down and turned his head towards Izuku in order to give him the most unimpressed look ever.

"I'm glad to know your brain still works, even if it seems to be as fucking dull as ever", he said simply, before picking his pencil up again and going back to taking notes. Izuku sighed – he knew that, no matter what he said, he was bound to receive a rude reply from Kacchan. Rubbing his eyes, he sat up on the bed.

"How long was I out for?", he asked, noticing that the curtain on the window had been drawn, but that the sky outside was dark and starry. The only source of light in the room was coming from a lamp on Kacchan's study desk.

"The whole day", Katsuki said, not looking at him. "It's almost 8 p.m. now".

"Really?", Izuku asked, surprised, eyebrows shooting up to the root of his hair.

"Do I look like I'm fucking joking?", Katsuki scoffed, grumpier than necessary. "Yeah, you slept the day away. You were tired as fuck. I, for one, am glad you did. I would tell you to do it every fucking day, but that would mean I'd be stuck in the bedroom with you".

“At least I feel better”, Izuku said, not sure what else he could respond. He began to stretch while he spoke, noticing the considerable improvement of his back and his shoulders. “How is your back?”

“It’s ok, now”, Katsuki said simply, as if he didn’t want to get into that subject.

“What are you doing?”, Izuku asked, leaning over in order to get a look at the notebook Katsuki was reading. Katsuki scoffed with annoyance.

“This is why I wish you’d just sleep the day away every fucking day”, he commented. “You’re more tolerable when your trap is shut”.

Izuku decided not to respond, even though he felt the deep urge to apologize. Years of being bullied did that to a person, but now he knew better. He had only asked Kacchan a simple question. If he was too grumpy to answer it properly, that was his problem, not Izuku’s.

Still, he wished he and Kacchan could talk. Just have normal conversations, chat with each other, communicate. They never seemed to be able to communicate unless it was through punches and screams. Now that he knew they shared their pain, Kacchan would probably avoid hurting him, lest he hurt himself, too. The screaming sessions would probably continue, though, and Izuku didn’t want that. He just wanted to be able to be himself without getting yelled at every other minute.

He missed his mom. He missed Uraraka, and Iida, and Todoroki. God, he probably even missed Mineta, if that was even possible. Even though the boy only talked about perverted subjects, at least he talked instead of shouting at Izuku.

“Ok, what?”, Kacchan all but threw his pencil at his desk with such intensity that it bounced off and fell to the floor. He turned around in order to glare at Izuku, looking furious, and the tone in his voice made the boy flinch, despite of himself. Old habits die hard. Noticing his display of weakness and feeling embarrassed by it, Izuku regained his composure and stood up straight, staring down at Katsuki with a serious look.

“I don’t know what you’re talking about”, he said sternly. Even though he was feeling well-rested and overall better about himself, he was also feeling very miserable about his mom and his friends, which made him feel not-at-all in the mood to deal with Kacchan’s sour temper.

“Cut the crap”, Katsuki stood up from his chair and removed his glasses, placing them on the desk. He took a step closer to Izuku. “I told you that because of this shared-feelings bullshit, you’ll have to tell me when you feel like shit, because I’m not about to be all miserable and moping because your stupid ass was too much of a wuss to tell me something’s wrong. I ain’t repeating myself, so just tell me what it is so we can fix it”, he demanded. Izuku felt embarrassed.

“It’s nothing”, he said simply, swallowing dry. How could he tell Kacchan without being ridiculed? How could he be honest without being yelled at?

“Bullshit”, Katsuki growled, taking another step closer to him. “And you know it”.

Izuku turned his face away so that he wouldn't have to look at Katsuki, biting his lower lip and staying in silence.

"Fine", Katsuki huffed after Izuku gave no indication he was about to continue. "See if I fucking care".

He sat back on his chair, picking his pencil from the floor and going back to writing. Izuku sat down on the bed and tried to focus on feeling better for Kacchan's sake, but the more he tried not to think about his mom, the more he thought about her. The more he thought about her, the more it hurt. Before he knew it, Izuku's eyes were overflowing with tears and his face was stuck in a permanent grimace as he tried his best not to cry. It didn't take Kacchan too long to get up from his seat again, looking furious, and Izuku found his crimson eyes to be filled with tears as well. His shock overrode his sadness for a moment, because he didn't remember ever seeing Kacchan cry.

No, that was a lie. He had seen Kacchan cry, but only once.

(Why was I the one who ended All Might?)

"Just fucking stop that already!", Katsuki demanded, voice breaking, and Izuku was too busy staring up at him in shock to formulate a response. The boy sniffed and ran his hands over his eyes in order to wipe the tears away, looking confused, angry, and miserable, all at the same time. Izuku got to his feet and reached a hand towards him, withdrawing it before he actually managed to touch Kacchan.

"Kacchan", was all Izuku managed to say, hand still lingering in the empty space between them, a concerned look on his face. Katsuki turned away from him, breathing heavily, looking like he was having a breakdown. Izuku couldn't remember ever seeing Kacchan so frantic, and felt guilty for being the one responsible for that. It became clear to him in that moment that Katsuki did not have the emotional capacity to deal with his own feelings and Izuku's at the same time, especially since he had probably never experienced anything like Izuku's feelings of misery and loneliness in his life. Perhaps that was the reason why an emotion that felt slightly uncomfortable to Izuku presented itself as something huge to Katsuki.

Izuku thought back at Kacchan's freaking out at the classroom, before. Izuku had been excited to see his friends, miserable for being unable to communicate with them, and nervous about all the questions they were making. He was feeling all those things at once, which meant Kacchan had been feeling all those things at once, too. Kacchan, who had never had real friends until UA, who had never felt misery and sadness in the same way as Izuku had, who had never felt nervous about anything. It was only natural his body panicked upon having all those unprecedented feelings shoved upon him in an unhealthy mix. The guilt in Izuku only increased, especially because in the same way Katsuki could feel what he felt, Izuku could feel Katsuki's confusion and anger bubbling up in his chest.

Izuku took a deep breath, closing his eyes and doing his best to concentrate and be rational. He could still hear Kacchan's heavy breathing from somewhere near him, but did his best to focus. He was going to see his mother again. He was going to see his friends. He would find a way to get back to his body and leave this situation behind him. All Might and Aizawa

sensei were working on fixing things. They were pro-heroes. They would be able to help him. Kacchan would be able to find a way, too. It was going to be fine. There was no reason to be sad about it. There was no reason to be nervous. He was ok. He was well-rested. He was going to be fine. He was going to be fine.

They were going to be fine.

Izuku opened his eyes again. Katsuki's face was red and he looked angrier than usual, but he was staring at Izuku with a weird expression, as if trying to read him.

"I – I think I figured out what was wrong", Izuku explained hesitantly, not sure how to put it into words. "Does it feel better, now?"

"Kind of", Katsuki admitted, saying the words as if they tasted sour on his tongue. "But this can't keep fucking happening, especially when we're out in public, shitty Deku", he added, sounding almost resentful, as if he thought Izuku was doing it on purpose.

"I'm sorry", he said, felling rightful this time. "I'll try to keep it at bay".

"Are you going to fucking tell me what this shitshow was about or what?", Katsuki demanded again, sounding furious but looking shaken. Izuku noticed his hands were trembling slightly, but decided not to comment on it. He figured that Kacchan deserved to know what had caused him to feel so emotional, even if Izuku didn't feel particularly comfortable sharing it with him.

"I was just – I was –", he tried to say, but it came out as a stuttering mess. Closing his eyes and taking a deep breath, he decided to start again. "I did have a dream. But it wasn't bad, it was just… weird".

Katsuki continued to stare at him as he waited for him to continue, crimson eyes so intense that Izuku felt his skin crawling. Still, he forced himself to go on.

"I was with my friends. My mom was there, too. Everything was ok, and I was happy…", he explained, not meeting Katsuki's eyes out of embarrassment. His fingers played absentmindedly with the hem of his shirt. "But then, everyone disappeared. I was completely alone. I think I got nervous because of this. I mean, you're the only one who can see me and who can talk to me, and if you stopped doing that… What would I be? Just a ghost, stuck in the void, screaming without being heard, existing without being seen. I think I'm scared of being stuck like this forever, and… I think I'm scared I'll end up all alone. Away from my body, from everyone I love… A-Away from you", he admitted, finally raising his eyes to look at Kacchan's face.

There was a pregnant pause during which Katsuki absorbed everything Deku was telling him and thought about it. It seemed like an eternity before he spoke again, looking way more well-composed than he had been a few minutes before.

"Tch. You really think I'll let that happen, stupid Deku?", he scoffed, but there was no mocking or teasing in his tone. If anything, he looked uncannily serious. "I told you. There's no way I'll surpass you if you're dead. No one will praise me for being better than a dead

guy. So I'm not letting that happen", he said. "There's no point in surpassing a ghost, either. So I'll find a way to shove you back into your body if it's the last thing I do, you hear me?", he raised his eyebrows.

Izuku gave Katsuki a tiny chuckle, smiling softly. Yeah, he should have known Kacchan would say something like that. He tried to pretend that Kacchan cared and that was his stupid way of trying to comfort him without being too obvious about it, but deep down, Izuku knew he was being honest. Kacchan didn't care about him. He only cared about surpassing him. As much as Izuku wished that they could be friends, he also knew that they weren't. They had crossed the event horizon of friendship a long time ago. They had already passed the point of no return.

"You're still sad", Katsuki interrupted his thoughts, making Izuku look up at him again. Katsuki was staring at him with intense crimson eyes.

"Yes", Izuku admitted tiredly. What was the point of lying? Kacchan would feel the truth, no matter how much he denied it.

"Look, nerd", Katsuki sighed, sounding more mature than Izuku remembered hearing him. That was enough to make him pay close attention. Katsuki ran a tired hand across his face and leaned forwards on his chair, his knees supporting his elbows as he hunched over. "I don't know how the fuck this connection between us works, but what I just felt – it was real. I still think you're a fucking crybaby and you get way too upset at the smallest things, but I'm gonna be honest with you. I don't want to feel like that. I'm aware this is selfish as fuck, but it is what it is. Just tell me what the problem is so we can do something about it and I can go the fuck back to studying".

Izuku eyed Kacchan with wary eyes. He couldn't say he wasn't thankful for his honesty, at least.

"I miss mom", Izuku admitted, shrugging and averting his eyes from Katsuki. "I miss Uraraka-san, and Iida-kun, and Todoroki-kun. I miss my friends. I miss All Might. But – I – I think I miss my mom the most. I wish I could see her".

"Tch", Katsuki said, scoffing and turning back on his chair so that he was facing his desk again. Izuku had to admit that was a politer response than he had been expecting.

They were silent for a while. Katsuki didn't go back to studying, but he wasn't looking at Izuku, either. Izuku simply sat at the edge of Katsuki's bed and stared at the floor, starting to get lost in deep thought. He could hear the sound of his friends chatting in the common room downstairs, and the sound of crickets outside Katsuki's window.

It felt like an eternity before Katsuki stood up again, closing both notebooks and the window. Izuku eyed him with curiosity, not moving from his spot on the bed as Katsuki removed his shirt and his sweatpants, opening the door of his wardrobe and standing only in his boxers. He turned his head to send Izuku a glare from above his shoulder.

"Don't fucking stare, creepy nerd", he growled simply, which made Izuku immediately turn his head away in embarrassment. Izuku heard the shuffling of drawers being opened and

clothes being wore, but he didn't dare look.

"W-What are you doing, Kacchan?", he asked eventually, eyes closed and head turned towards the door. He suspected he might have been blushing, but couldn't tell for sure.

"We're going downstairs", Katsuki explained briefly, as if that information was all Izuku had to know.

"What?!", Izuku exclaimed, confused. "W-Why? What for?"

Katsuki sighed loudly at this, and Izuku didn't have to open his eyes in order to picture the way Kacchan must have eyerolled.

"Didn't you just say you miss your shitty-ass friends?", he asked with annoyance. "I'm taking you downstairs so you can see them. This way, you won't feel like shit, which means I won't feel like shit. Now shut up and tag along", he instructed, making his way to the door.

"W-Wait, Kacchan!", Izuku protested as Katsuki pulled the door open unceremoniously and walked out. "I thought you had to study!", he called after him.

"I do, but I can't study while your lame feelings nag at my brain. It's distracting as fuck", he huffed, closing the door with his key and shoving it at his pocket. "Also, I'm almost done anyway. I can finish it later".

"A-Are you sure?", Izuku asked, nervous. "I mean, if you want to, you can finish studying –"

"Listen, shitty Deku", Katsuki said, stopping on his tracks and grabbing one of Izuku's forearm with more strength than necessary. He loosened his grip as soon as he felt the pain erupt on his own forearm, but Izuku never protested. "The last thing I want to do is go downstairs and socialize with a bunch of extras who can barely stand me. But if I don't do it, you'll keep moping in my bedroom, I'll keep feeling like shit, and neither of us will get anything done because we'll be too busy crying over each other's feelings. So I'm looking at this like when you need to swallow a gross medicine in order to get better quicker. We'll go to the common room, I'll endure a few minutes of conversation with that bunch of dumbasses, then we'll get back here and you'll stop. Being. So. Fucking. Sad. Ok?", he tightened his grip on Izuku's arm as if to squeeze a response out of him. Izuku merely stared at him with wide eyes and nodded. "Good. Now let's get this over with".

Izuku followed Katsuki silently as they made their way down the stairs, staying a few steps behind him and trying his best not to let his excitement take the best of him. Even though he knew Kacchan was only doing that so that he would stop feeling bad himself, Izuku was still grateful to him.

All conversation in the common run was cut short as soon as Katsuki stepped in, a grumpy look on his face and his hands shoved in his pockets. He didn't meet anyone's eyes as he stopped in front of the couches where everyone was gathered, head turned to the side and shoulders hunched over. The first one to greet him was Kirishima, who hopped off the sofa looking much like an excited puppy.

“Bakubro!”, he exclaimed, making his way over to Katsuki. That was the cue everyone else needed to greet him as well.

“He finally stepped out of his cave!”, Sero cheered.

“Bukubro! I missed you! How are you doing?”, Mina was right after Kirishima, throwing herself on Katsuki and hugging him briefly. Katsuki stood exactly where he was, hands still shoved in his pockets and not returning the hug, but he didn’t shove the girl away, either.

“Hey, Kacchan! How’s the head?”, Kaminari asked. Izuku’s face immediately scrunched up in a frown.

“W-What did Kaminari-kun just call you?”, he asked Katsuki, receiving no response. If anything, Katsuki seemed to avoid his eyes after the question.

“Bakugou! It is good to see you”, Iida was the next to greet him, gesticulating widely. “Are you feeling better? How is your concussion?”

Probably noticing the way Katsuki was shrinking further into himself as if he was trying his best to keep himself from exploding the entire room into oblivion, Kirishima remembered his friend’s request and stood in front of him almost defensively, an apologetic smile on his face and his arms raised carefully as if to indicate for everyone else to step back.

“Hey guys, how about we give Bakugou some space, huh?”, he suggested, gesturing for everyone to stay away. Iida was the only one who obeyed, immediately stepping aside so that Katsuki could walk through if he wanted, whereas Mina and Kaminari stayed exactly where they were. Kirishima gave them a serious look and nodded to the couch, urgency written in his eyes. “C’mon, guys. Back off a bit, ok?”, he added in a lower tone so that only the two friends could hear. Mina frowned and stepped away too, pulling Kaminari along with her when the boy did nothing.

Only when the path was clear and no one else was asking him questions did Katsuki walk further into the room, still not meeting anyone’s eyes and throwing himself on the sofa, as far away from everyone else as possible. On the same sofa as him sat Sero and Round Face, whereas on the other there was Frog Girl, Earphone Girl and Yaoyorozu. Kaminari took the seat next to Jirou, whereas Mina and Kirishima took the floor directly in front of them. Iida, on the other hand, chose to remain on his feet, even though Katsuki couldn’t tell if he had been there from the beginning.

“So, Bakugou”, Mina asked carefully, breaking the otherwise silent room. “Are you hungry?”

Upon the girl’s question, Katsuki’s stomach grumbled, and he realized for the first time he hadn’t eaten in a long time. For the past few days, he had waited until it was far deep into the night before he grabbed himself something to eat, meaning to avoid meeting people on his way to the kitchen. Having slept most of the afternoon away and done nothing other than study once he woke up, Katsuki didn’t even consider grabbing himself a bite until Mina suggested it.

“I’ll make us something”, Katsuki announced simply. He supposed that counted as an apology for freaking out on them and exploding shit back at the classroom, even though it hadn’t been his fault. Plus, this was a far better option than just sitting there at the couch – this way, he could do something he enjoyed (cooking) and avoid talking to everyone at once. Mina and Kaminari cheered happily at the announcement – they adored Katsuki’s cooking, as did everyone else with a functional tongue –, whereas Kirishima simply eyed him with suspicion. Katsuki simply stood up from the couch and made his way to the kitchen, Deku following him close behind.

“So”, Katsuki asked once he reached the kitchen. “What do you feel like eating?”

“Are – are you asking me?”, Izuku frowned, confused, standing beside Katsuki with a confused look and sending eventual glances back at the common room, as if he longed to go back and stay near his friends.

“I’m sure one of them is about to burst in any second now and beg to talk to you as if I’m some sort of walking Ouija board or some shit, so quit trying to go back there. You’re gonna end up dragging me with you”, Katsuki scoffed, not looking at Izuku as he assessed the ingredients available in the fridge. “And yes, I’m not out of my fucking mind just yet, so you’re the only one I could have been talking to. What d’ya want?”

Izuku frowned slightly, re-approaching Katsuki.

“Does it really matter?”, Izuku asked. “I mean, I won’t be able to eat it”.

“But I will”, Katsuki shrugged, putting an apron on and grabbing a knife, even though he hadn’t picked any ingredients yet. “If I can feel your stupid feelings, I’m pretty sure you can feel mine, too. Maybe if I eat something you like, your shitty-ass brain will get less sappy over everything”.

Izuku couldn’t help but to smile at this, looking at Katsuki with fondness.

“Are you really that driven to make me happy, Kacchan?”, he asked, no malice in his voice. Katsuki’s grip on the knife grew harder.

“You’re basically begging me to find out if I can stab you with this knife right now”, he said through gritted teeth, sending Izuku a death glare.

“Fine, sorry”, Izuku chuckled, lowering his head. “I – I like katsudon”, he shrugged, not meeting Katsuki’s eyes. “Can you make that?”

“I’ll see what I can do”, Katsuki scoffed, going over a mental list of ingredients and checking if they were all available in the kitchen.

Just as Katsuki had expected, it didn’t take too long for someone to come after him in the kitchen. To no one’s surprise, that someone was Round Face, who looked very embarrassed to be there alone with Katsuki and who wasn’t meeting his eyes. Back at the common room, their friends’ conversation had returned to top volume.

“U-Uraraka-san!”, Izuku exclaimed in embarrassment, eyes widening as his friend entered the kitchen hesitantly.

“See? Told you it was only a matter of time before one of the fuckers showed up”, Katsuki said without looking at her, grabbing the ingredients he needed from the bottom of the fridge. Uraraka’s eyes widened upon the comment, since she hadn’t heard Izuku’s side of the conversation. It was still a bit hard for 1-A to get used to see Katsuki talking to thin air and remembering that was Izuku he was speaking to.

“H-How is your head, Bakugou-kun?”, Uraraka asked politely, standing in front of the kitchen counter on the opposite side from Katsuki, who rolled his eyes.

“Tch. Don’t pretend you care, Round Face. Just ask what you want to know”, he said, straight to the point.

“Ahh, Kacchan! Don’t be rude!”, Izuku protested, blushing.

“I wasn’t pretending. I really do want to know”, Uraraka protested, looking offended. “Even if that is not the only reason I am here”.

“Yeah, I know why you’re here”, Katsuki scoffed, starting to prepare Deku’s damn katsudon. “My head is fine”.

“That’s good to know”, Uraraka continued, polite. Katsuki sighed.

“Yeah. Now, what do you want?”

“Kacchan!”

“I want to know about Deku-kun”, Uraraka said, a tiny blush appearing on her face as well, even though her eyes were determined.

“He’s fine. He’s standing beside me, blushing like a motherfucker and telling me to stop being rude. I think I’m gonna ignore that last part”, Katsuki shrugged, not looking at Uraraka as he spoke.

“K-Kacchan!!!”

“He – He’s blushing?”, Uraraka’s eyes widened. “W-Why?”

“I dunno, he probably has a crush on you or something”, Katsuki scoffed with an evil smirk, only to immediately feel like he had been punched in the gut. Looking at Deku, he found the boy to be looking extremely pale with wide eyes, starting at him as if he couldn’t believe Katsuki had said something like that. Given the rising anxiety inside Katsuki’s own chest, he decided it was time to stop teasing Deku, lest he became the one to feel the aftereffects of his own words.

“W-What?!”, Uraraka exclaimed, face gaining a bright red tone. Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“I’m just fucking with you, Round Face”, Katsuki said, ignoring the way Deku was burying his face between his hands beside him. “Anyway, if that’s all you want to know, you can fuck off, now”.

“Oh my god”, Izuku groaned pitifully, voice muffled.

“I – I don’t –“, Uraraka stuttered, still taken aback by Katsuki’s statement and blushing violently. She took a few seconds to regain her composure before continuing, frowning at Katsuki’s cooking. “A-Are… Are you going to make katsudon?”, she asked, awkward, clearly trying to change the subject and ease the tension in the kitchen. Katsuki rolled his eyes again.

“I don’t do small talk”, he said simply, continuing to look anywhere but her.

“It’s not small talk”, Uraraka protested, sounding offended again. “It was a serious question”.

“Yeah, I’m making katsudon. Great observation skills. If you don’t have any more relevant questions, you can fuck off and tell the next person who wants to know about Deku to come in”, Katsuki dismissed her. Uraraka looked angry, all of a sudden, her face returning to its natural color.

“Is this what we are to you?”, she asked, indignant. “A line of people you have to deal with before you’re allowed back to your room?”

Katsuki halted his knife cutting in order to stare up at Uraraka, an annoyed look on his face. She didn’t wait for a response before continuing.

“Kirishima-kun has been worried sick about you. So have Mina and Kaminari-kun, and Sero-kun, and Iida-kun. We all have worried about you. We worry about Deku-kun, too, but one thing doesn’t erase the other. If you don’t care about those who aren’t close to you, at least respect those who are. We are not costumers or fans waiting in line to see you. We are your colleagues and friends”.

Katsuki huffed out an annoyed breath, going back to cutting the ingredients. Uraraka continued to stare at him.

“Whatever, Round Face”, he muttered. Uraraka sighed.

“If you want to be like that, fine”, Uraraka said, looking resigned. “But I want to make sure you are being nice to Deku-kun”.

“The fuck do you care? Do you have a crush on him?”, Katsuki said, more out of anger than anything. Round Face was annoying the fuck out of him, so he might as well annoy her back.

“Kacchan, please, stop doing this”, Izuku asked, sounding pained. “Just talk to her normally. Tell her I’m doing fine and that I miss her and Iida-kun!”

The blush returned to Uraraka’s face as violently as ever, but she didn’t stand down.

“H-He’s my friend”, she tried to protest, but the stuttering removed all certainty she might have tried to put in her voice. “And, knowing you, I can’t be sure you are not mistreating him”.

“I’m cooking katsudon”, Katsuki pointed out, raising a triumphant eyebrow at her. “Do you count that as mistreating him?”

“Kacchan, please –“, Izuku tried again.

“Shut up, Deku”.

“What is he saying?”, Uraraka asked, her attention perking up at the mention of Izuku.

“What does it matter to you?”, Katsuki immediately responded, more out of instinct than anything else. Frustrated, he settled the knife down and turned to Izuku. “Look, this isn’t working out. Your friends are too damn annoying. Isn’t just looking at them enough? Do I really have to interact?”, he asked, tired and annoyed. Izuku looked upset by this.

“I didn’t ask you to do this, Kacchan”, Izuku pointed out, frowning. “You’re the one who offered to do it. And you’re the one who’s being rude to them for no reason!”

“Yeah, because I thought that you just seeing them would be enough to make my stomach stop hurting so much, but now it’s getting even worse!”, Katsuki protested angrily. “Can’t you just get your shit together, stupid Deku?”

“How am I supposed to get my shit together when you’re the one who’s fucking teasing my friends and making stuff up instead of being useful?!”, Izuku exclaimed angrily, his face scrunched up in rage. Katsuki’s eyes widened in shock, and it took Izuku a few seconds longer than he should have to realize what he had just said.

“What happened? What’s going on?”, Uraraka asked, nervous, noticing the obvious change in Katsuki’s face.

“Did you just – did you just curse at me?”, Katsuki asked, eyebrows perking up. Izuku blushed and covered his mouth with both hands, eyes so wide they looked like they were about to pop out of his skull.

“Oh my god”, Izuku said, voice barely above a whisper and sounding horrified. “Oh my god, mom, I’m sorry!”, he exclaimed, even though his mom was nowhere around. For some reason, Katsuki found the whole thing – Deku cursing for what was probably the first time in his life and then immediately apologizing to his absent mother as if he was a 4-year-old – extremely funny. Before he knew better – before he even remembered Round Face was standing there as a witness – he burst out in a laughing fit that was harder than any he could remember having. Uraraka seemed a mixture of horrified and uncomfortable to witness that, feeling as if she was intruding a deeply private moment. Besides, Katsuki was looking a bit maniacal like that, talking to an invisible person, holding a knife and laughing his ass off in the kitchen while he cooked katsudon at 8 p.m. She unconsciously took a step back.

“Oh my fucking god”, Katsuki laughed, pointing at Deku. “Oh my fucking god, that’s ridiculous. Oh my god”, he bent over, trying to catch his breath.

“Kacchan, stop laughing! It’s not funny!”, Izuku protested, mortified.

“It’s fucking hilarious, Deku”, he continued laughing, unaware of the retreating Uraraka. “Is this – is this the first time you ever cursed? Like, the first time ever?”, he asked, looking at Izuku as if he was the most pathetic person he had ever seen. Izuku blushed.

“It’s not my fault! If you can feel it when I’m sad, then I can feel it when you’re angry, too! It was your anger talking! Just like when you cried earlier!”, he accused.

“Oi! Don’t ever bring that up again!”, Katsuki immediately became defensive, pointing his knife at Izuku. “That only happened because of your shitty feelings!”

“Well, I can tell you the same! That wasn’t my fault!”, Izuku protested, also defensive. He looked deeply ashamed and embarrassed, hiding his face behind his hands again. “Oh my god, please don’t tell my mom. And – oh, my god, please don’t tell All Might, Kacchan!”, he begged.

“Oh, I’m definitely telling All Might”, Katsuki grinned evilly, going back to chopping ingredients off. “It’s the first thing I’m gonna tell him the moment I see him”.

“Nooooo”, Izuku moaned pitifully, continuing to hide behind his hands.

“Anyway, if you have a better plan about talking to Round Face – hey, where the fuck did she go?”, Katsuki asked, finally noticing Uraraka’s absence. The kitchen was empty of anyone other than himself and Deku.

“Oh”, Izuku said, almost disappointed. He looked around, as if hoping to find Uraraka hiding somewhere. “I didn’t see her leave”.

“Tch. Whatever. Better for me”, Katsuki scoffed, absentmindedly preparing their meal. He hoped it would be enough to feed everyone in the common room.

“I think them talking to you isn’t a good idea, Kacchan”, Izuku pointed out hesitantly.

“Fucking finally. Can we go back to my room, now?”, Katsuki huffed, unimpressed.

“No – I mean”, Izuku corrected himself, looking a bit embarrassed. “It’s because, when they talk to you, it’s not me they’re talking to. So maybe – maybe I could tell you what I want to say to them, and you can relay the message? Just this time?”, he asked, hope evident in his big, green eyes. Katsuki stared at him for a moment before scoffing.

“Told you I’m not your fucking delivery boy”, he said, going back to looking grumpy.

“I know that, Kacchan”, Izuku sighed impatiently. “But it would be better than having you argue with everyone who tries to talk to you! This way you can just reassure them I’m fine, and then they’ll stop asking questions”.

Katsuki was silent after huffing out an annoyed breath, continuing to prepare the katsudon without meeting Izuku's eyes. He had a grumpy expression on, eyebrows scrunched up in anger.

"Uh… Is everything ok?", Kirishima's head popped up in the kitchen, like he didn't want to walk in all the way. "Ochako came back looking terrified and she said you were laughing manically while holding a knife", he explained, looking half-concerned. Katsuki glared at him.

"'M fine", he grumbled with annoyance, not looking at Kirishima.

"Ok…", Kirishima said hesitantly, slowly backing away and disappearing.

"Tch. Can't even laugh in peace without these fuckers meddling in my business", Katsuki complained, continuing to cook.

"I don't think Uraraka-san had ever seen you laugh before", Izuku pointed out, supporting his cheek with one hand as he leaned over the counter and watched Katsuki cook.

"So what? It's not a big deal", Katsuki scoffed.

"You did look kind of terrifying", Izuku shrugged.

"I'm always fucking terrifying", Katsuki protested. "That's the whole point of me".

"No, it's not!", Izuku chuckled.

"Shut the fuck up. What do you even know about me?", Katsuki scoffed. Izuku looked a bit sad and nostalgic at the words.

"I think it's safe to say I know a lot", he said in a small voice.

"Tch. As if", was all Katsuki responded. Izuku decided not to argue.

Katsuki continued to cook the katsudon in silence, neither him or Deku engaging in conversation again. They could still hear the muffled chatter coming from the common room, but now the voices were lower, probably so that the two boys wouldn't be able to overhear what they were saying. Katsuki decided to wait in the kitchen for the meal to get ready, not wanting to spend more time than necessary with his friends. He began scrolling through his phone absentmindedly while he waited for the katsudon to cook.

"So", Izuku said after minutes of absolute silence, still leaning over the counter beside Katsuki. "Have you considered what I said?"

"There's nothing to consider", Katsuki responded simply, without looking up from the phone.

"Kacchan", Izuku said seriously. "You didn't come all the way down here just to cook our friends a meal and then leave. You – You said you wanted me to stop feeling sad".

“Just so I stop feeling sad, too”, Katsuki pointed out, sounding way too defensive. Izuku sighed.

“Yes. But – saying that stuff to Uraraka-san and not talking to anyone isn’t helping”, he admitted.

“So what, shitty Deku? I’m not your servant boy. I’m not here to attend to your every fucking wish”, Katsuki placed his phone down angrily, glaring at Izuku. “So my attempt at making things better didn’t work. Then what? Why don’t you just try sucking it up and dealing with it like a man instead of crying like a little baby over everything that goes wrong in your shitty life?”, he replied angrily.

Realization dawned on Izuku at Katsuki’s unprovoked rage.

He only realized it because of the twisting feeling in his gut, the painful squeezing of his chest, and the frantic beating of his heart. There was no reason for Izuku to feel any of those things, so that could only mean he was mirroring Katsuki’s feelings. Everything suddenly made sense.

“You’re scared”, Izuku pointed out blatantly, looking surprised. Katsuki froze, glaring at him. If looks could kill, Izuku would have been fulminated on the spot.

“I’m not scared of anything”, Katsuki growled through gritted teeth, furious. “Shut the fuck up. You don’t know what you’re talking about”.

“Kacchan”, Izuku insisted. “I can feel it”.

“That’s your own fucking fear you’re feeling, then, you stupid ass”, he protested, getting up and walking away from Izuku. The boy stood up as well and followed him.

“I have no reason to be scared right now”, Izuku shook his head, feeling particularly brave. “You have”.

Katsuki turned on his heels, looking like he was close to smacking Izuku, but the boy continued, unfaltering.

“You think they’ll think less of you if you help me. You think they’ll see it as a weakness if you help the one person who has been nothing but your rival so far”, Izuku said before Katsuki could do anything. “But that’s not true. They’ll see it as kindness”, he pointed out with a hesitant smile.

“That’s worse”, Katsuki scowled. Izuku frowned.

“What? Why?”, he asked, confused. Katsuki scoffed at him and shook his head.

“If there’s one thing I’m not is kind, shitty Deku”, he said with a humorless smile. “You, of all people, should know that”.

“Ok, you do have a point”, Izuku admitted, nodding. “But people can change. I’ve changed”.

“Oh, yeah?”, Katsuki scoffed again. “Well, I don’t want to change”.

Izuku grew silent at this, staring at his childhood friend.

“You think what? Because we share a bed and I’m cooking for you that changes what we are? We aren’t friends, Deku. We’ll never be. We’re nothing but rivals who happened to get stuck together and now are surviving together. Once you get back to your body, everything will go back to the way it used to be. I won’t cook for you anymore. I won’t share a bed with you anymore. Hell, I probably won’t even talk to you anymore. I’m only doing those things because I have to – because I’m meant to, not because I want to. Because I’ll get a fucking headache and feel like shit if I don’t. Is that what you wanted to hear? Is that what you wanted to know?”

Izuku just stared at Katsuki.

“We used to be”.

“What?”

“We used to be. Friends, I mean. To this day, I never really figured out why we ever stopped”.

“Well, rack your fucking brains”.

“Yeah, I supposed you’re right. We stopped being friends because you had a quirk, and I didn’t”.

Katsuki glared at him.

“Yeah”.

“And you thought you were better than me. That I wasn’t worthy of your friendship”.

“Fucking right”.

“And you didn’t want anyone to know you used to be best friends with a quirkless loser”.

A scoff.

“But guess what, Kacchan?”, Izuku said, sniffing, holding back the tears that were pooling in his eyes. “I have a quirk now. And I’m making it my own. And, one day, the quirkless loser who you were ashamed of and who you abandoned will be better than you. And I’ll never, ever shove it in your face, because I don’t want to be a hero in order to surpass you or to be better. I want to be a hero to save people. Can you say the same?”

Silence.

The conversation in the common room continued.

It felt like an eternity of tense silence between them.

“You’re crying again”, Izuku said simply, turning away from Katsuki with the saddest expression on his face. Katsuki took a hand to his face and found it to be wet with tears. He stared in surprise and confusion. He hadn’t even realized he had been crying – only that his chest felt weirdly numb.

He stared at Izuku for several moments, confusion not evident on his face but clear in his eyes. Had he really hurt Deku that bad? Was a series of words capable of making Deku feel as bad as he was feeling on that moment? Was talking about their childhood so painful that it made Katsuki cry without even realizing it, just because he was mirroring Deku’s pain?

He didn’t want to think about it. He didn’t want to speak about it. The best course of action would be ignoring all that shit, eating his food and going back to the peace of his room. But still, Katsuki couldn’t help feeling guilty about the way he was feeling. He was only feeling so bad because Deku was feeling bad. Because he had made Deku feel bad.

Or maybe it was Deku’s accusation that was making him feel like an utter piece of shit.

I don’t want to be a hero in order to surpass you or to be better. I want to be a hero to save people. Can you say the same?

Could he say the same?

Katsuki didn’t know.

The katsudon got ready and Katsuki wiped his face away of any possible traces of tears on his face, not looking or speaking to Deku as he carefully grabbed the bowl and made his way back to the common room. He fucking hated himself for crying and ending up looking like a weak-ass loser, but managed to convince himself that all the crying was Deku’s fault, not his. Their friends’ chatter was interrupted by his arrival and they all cheered upon seeing him bringing them food, Yao-Momo and Tsuyu offering to go grab the plates and cups for their dinner. Katsuki placed the bowl in the center of the dining table and sat down on the farthest corner possible, vehemently ignoring Deku standing up in silence beside him.

Yao-Momo and Tsuyu came back with what was necessary and they all settled in order to eat. Katsuki realized Uraraka was avoiding looking at his general direction, whereas Kirishima didn’t seem to be able to take his eyes off him. Maybe he knew something was wrong. Maybe he knew how shitty Katsuki was feeling.

That wasn’t possible, though. Not even Katsuki knew how he was feeling.

Was his pain Deku’s? Or was it his own? He had no fucking idea, and no way to tell, either.

They began to eat, everyone continuing to chatter lively as they went, miraculously not asking Katsuki anymore questions or pressing him into talking. They could probably see it in his face that he wasn’t in the mood for conversation. He would probably feel the need to thank Kirishima for that later, if he was the type of person to display gratitude.

Behind him, Katsuki could hear Deku sniffing as he tried to hold back his tears. Katsuki didn’t have to look at Izuku to know that he was crying, because his chest was aching and

throbbing with each breath he took.

Sighing, Katsuki finished his meal as fast as he could, trying not to think too much about how delicious it tasted. He cleared his throat, interrupting Kaminari in whatever shitty story he was in the middle of making up. All eyes turned to look at him, even Uraraka's, however apprehensive they were. He, on his turn, didn't meet anyone's face as he spoke, choosing to stare at the table instead.

"Deku wants to say some shit for you all", he announced crudely, not even looking at Deku. "Since he can't say it directly and none of you fuckers have any idea what you want to ask him in the first place, I'll just tell you what he wants to say. Who do you want to start with?", he turned his head to look at Deku, careful to keep his face impassive and neutral.

Deku stared back at him with surprise in his wet eyes. He hesitated for a few moments, looking like he was trying to decide whether Katsuki was playing a prank on him or not, before managing to muster a response.

"U-Uraraka-san", he said. Katsuki suppressed the urge to roll his eyes and listened to the words Deku wanted him to relay.

"He wants to apologize for what I said to you in the kitchen and let you know that those words were entirely mine, not his", Katsuki told Uraraka with a bored expression. "He misses you and Four Eyes – fine, fine, Iida – and he wants you to know he's very grateful for everything you've been doing for him so far, even though none of you have done shit – ok, this last part was me, not him. He wants you to know he's ok, and told you not to worry about him, no matter how bad his body looks. He says you don't need to be nervous because he'll find a way out of this, things will go back to normal soon, blah blah blah. Fine, is that all? Who do you want to declare yourself to next?"

This went on for some minutes, Izuku telling Katsuki what he wanted his friends to know and Katsuki doing his best to relay the messages without altering them too much. His friends listened with sharp attention and seemed to get emotional by Deku's words – Uraraka started crying at some point and Kirishima was obviously fighting back tears. When Deku made Katsuki tell the boy that he thought it was manly to cry, Kirishima burst like a dam, making Katsuki roll his eyes and bury his face between his knees.

Once they were done, Katsuki felt exhausted. Looking up at Deku, he found the boy had heavy bags beneath his eyes, face paler than usual. It dawned upon Katsuki that maybe bird-brain's theory made sense – maybe Deku was drawing his lifeforce out. But maybe, just maybe, he was drawing Deku's lifeforce out as well.

They couldn't keep going like this.

After everyone hugged – thankfully, they were all smart enough to not try and hug him – and cried like pathetic babies about Deku, Katsuki bid his sharp goodnight to his friend and headed back to his bedroom. He could tell Deku was still sad, but it was a different kind of sadness, now – a lighter kind of sadness. A sadness he would deal with later, when he was well-rested and not feeling like literal shit.

They walked all the way back to the bedroom in silence, entered the room in silence. Katsuki changed his clothes in silence. Deku lied on the bed in silence. Only after Katsuki went to the bathroom and came back ready to get to bed that he realized Deku was lying at the edge of the bed again.

“Move over”, Katsuki instructed, grabbing the pillows he needed to form a pillow fort.

“What?”, Izuku asked dryly, not understanding the command and clearly still upset about their discussion in the kitchen, even though Katsuki had done what he had asked and spoken to his shitty friends for him. What more did Deku want?

“Sleep on the other side of the bed. I can’t get out easily from there if I need to use the bathroom. You don’t need to use the bathroom, so move over”, he instructed as patiently as he could, which was saying much about how benevolent he was feeling on that moment.

“But you said you would blow me up if I slept on your side of the bed”, Izuku frowned, genuinely confused. He still looked upset, and, for some reason, that annoyed Katsuki. Whatever resemblance of patience he had managed to muster had lasted for precisely 3 seconds, and it was entirely gone now.

“Well, I’m fucking taking that back now”, Katsuki scoffed, losing his temper. “Move or I’ll move you”.

“Fine”, Izuku agreed, moving over to Katsuki’s previous side of the bed. He looked like he didn’t want to argue anymore and, before Katsuki had even put up the pillow fort, he was already lying as closely to the wall as possible, his back turned to his childhood friend.

Once he was done establishing the limit on the middle of the bed, Katsuki lay down on his back and stared up at the ceiling. Peeking over at Deku’s side, he found the boy in the same fetal position, back turned to him, face hidden by his green curls. Somehow, Katsuki could tell he wasn’t asleep.

They stayed in silence for a long time, just breathing and staring at nothing for what felt like an eternity. Katsuki was the first one to break the silence.

“I don’t do apologies”.

A scoff.

“I know that”.

“Shut up”.

“You’re the one who started it”.

“Whatever. What I mean is – I don’t apologize”.

“I said I know that”.

“Are you gonna let me say what I want to fucking say or will you keep being like this?”

Silence.

“Look. I was an asshole as a kid. I’m still an asshole, but – I didn’t know”.

“Know what?”

“How much I hurt you. I mean, I did those things to hurt you, but not to hurt hurt you, you know?”

“… No”.

A sigh.

“Look. I’m not good at this. Can’t you at least put a fucking effort into understanding?”

“I’m trying, but it’s not my fault you’re not good at this”.

“God, you’re so fucking annoying”.

A spike of pain in Katsuki’s heart.

“Stop doing that”.

“I’m not doing it on purpose!”

“Sure feels like it!”

“If you don’t want to feel pain, then don’t make me feel it”.

Silence.

“Listen, Deku – what I’m trying to say is: I didn’t know how much I hurt you until I felt it firsthand. I don’t know what I was trying to do, but I didn’t mean for you to be in so much pain. So my bad, I guess”.

A humorless chuckle.

“Really? ‘My bad’?”

“I don’t know what you want me to say”.

“I don’t know. A proper apology would be nice”.

“I told you I don’t fucking do apologies”.

“Then you’re going to have to do better than ‘my bad’”.

“Tch. You think way too much of yourself”.

“You told me to kill myself”.

Silence. A renewed spike of pain, older this time.

“Do you remember that?”

Silence.

“Yeah”.

“Yeah”.

“I didn’t mean it”.

“I don’t think it really matters what you meant, Kacchan”.

A flash of anger and resentment.

“You know, you seem really eager to be friends with the guy you keep insisting hurts you so much. If I was that much of an asshole, if I hurt you so bad, then just leave me alone and stop insisting on this friendship bullshit”.

Pain.

“Fine”.

A smothering feeling. Tears in his eyes.

“Listen, shitty Deku. I don’t want you to die. I never did. I was just more of an asshole than I am now. I said shit without thinking first. I still do, sometimes, but – I’m not like that anymore. Or at least I’m trying not to be”.

“Yeah, I know that”.

“Then just let it go, ok?”

“You’d like that, wouldn’t you?”

“What the fuck is that supposed to mean, you sassy son of a bitch?”

“It’s easier if I just forgive you without you actually having to apologize. But even if I do that, the pain won’t just go away”.

“Of course. Because it can’t be that fucking easy with you, can it?”

“Yeah”.

A scoff.

“How long have you been feeling it?”

“Hm?”

“This pain”.

“I don’t know. It gets better, sometimes”.

“When does it get worse?”

Silence.

“When you’re mean to me for no reason”.

“So all the time, then”.

A tiny chuckle. With humor, this time.

“Not always. Sometimes, when you’re not really thinking about it, you can be nice”.

“Not to you, though”.

“No. Not to me”.

Silence.

“But you’re nice to other people sometimes. Kirishima-kun, mostly. You’re friends with him. I think it’s good”.

“Huh”.

Pain.

“Just talk, Deku”.

“I just… I used to think we stopped being friends because of you. Because you couldn’t be friends with anyone. I was hurt, at first, but as we grew up, I… I thought you were the problem, not me. Even as amazing as you are”.

A pause.

“But you’re friends with Kirishima-kun, and with Kaminari-kun... So maybe the problem was me all along. And – and, today, Kaminari-kun called you Kacchan”.

“He only does it to piss me off”.

“Well, I don’t”.

A scoff.

“I really don’t”.

“Why the fuck else would you call me by my patronizing childhood nickname?”

Silence.

“See. It’s to piss me off”.

“It’s not. I swear”.

“Then just tell me why”.

“I can’t”.

“Why not?”

“It’s embarrassing”.

“Fuck you”.

Silence.

“I’ll tell you about it someday”.

“Whatever, shitty Deku. Until then, I’ll keep thinking it’s to piss me off”.

“Ok”.

Silence.

“I think I’ll go to sleep, now”.

“Whatever”.

“Goodnight”.

“No ‘Kacchan’, huh?”

“Do you want me to call you Kacchan?”

“No”.

“Ok, then. Goodnight, Kacchan”.

“Now you’re just being a piece of shit”.

“I think I can have this one after what you said tonight”.

A sigh.

“Not dropping it, huh?”

“You haven’t apologized yet”.

“And I won’t”.

“So I’m not dropping it, either”.

“Bitchy”.

“Rude”.

“Whatever”.

“Goodnight”.

“Whatever”.

Silence.

“Did you feel better?”

“Huh?”

“After I ate the katsudon. Did it help?”

“A bit, yeah. You cook really well”.

“I know that”.

A sigh.

“I’ll cook it more often, then”.

“I suppose it’s easier than apologizing, huh?”

“God. Fuck you. Shut up”.

Silence.

More silence.

“You’re such a fucking loser”.

More silence.

“What, you’re not talking to me anymore? Is that your level of bitchiness?”

“I thought you wanted me to shut up”.

“Fuck you”.

“See?”

A sigh.

“Look, Deku. I’ll try to be better, ok? I can’t promise I will always get it right, because you’re annoying as fuck, but – I don’t want to feel that shitty way anymore”.

Silence.

“And it wouldn’t be heroic for me to let you feel that way, either. So – if I’m being an asshole – just tell me”.

“You were an asshole tonight”.

A sigh.

“You do know ‘asshole’ counts as a curse word, right?”

“It’s your anger manifesting on me”.

“You tell yourself that. Your mouth is getting rotten. Like mine”.

“No, it’s not!”

“Trashmouth”.

“Don’t call me that!”

“I’ll tell your mom all about it”.

“Don’t you dare!”

“Will you forgive me if I don’t tell her?”

Silence. Sadness.

“No, Kacchan. I’m sorry, but it’s… It takes more than that. I wish I could. I mean, I don’t blame you for it, and I think I probably forgave you already, but – you keep – you keep doing this… stuff. And saying stuff. About us not… Well. It hurts. I can’t just… let it all go, you know”.

Silence. Disappointment.

“It was worth a try”.

“I suppose”.

Silence.

“I’ll find a way to make it up to you, then”.

“Why?”

“I don’t know. Because I feel like it. Don’t fucking question me”.

“You could just apologize. It’s simple like that”.

“I’ll apologize when I’m dead”.

“Or when I am”.

“Quit being so fucking sappy. You sound like that emo bird guy. I already told you you’re not going to die”.

A chuckle.

“Thanks, Kacchan”.

“So we’re back to Kacchan, huh?”

“Ugh”.

“Go to sleep, nerd. I need to be well-rested for class tomorrow”.

“Fine. You too”.

“Don’t tell me what to do”.

Chapter End Notes

I'm not saying Bakugou was jealous of Uraraka, but Bakugou was jealous of Uraraka
Will these two just TALK ABOUT FEELINGS already UGH
Trust me, I'm dying to just make Bakugou develop and grow but I don't want to rush things..... Unfortunately, with characters like him, I gotta take it slow. Who knows, maybe it will take something tragic for our Bakuboy to finally figure his shit out :-)
Hope you guys liked this one, even if it ended up more emotional than I had intended! I like the idea of them sharing feelings, thus making Bakugou feel Midoriya's sadness and grief for their lost friendship and making Midoriya feel... well. Bakugou's constant anger?
Let me know what you think! See you in the next update ;-)

Chapter 7: The Train Chapter

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku woke up.

He thankfully didn't have any weird dreams that night, probably because of the exhaustion he had been feeling before he went to sleep. His arguments with Kacchan always left him emotionally tired afterwards, making his bones feel heavy and his brain feel mushy, but the intensity of his exhaustion had only increased after his soul became attached to the boy's.

For most of his life, all Izuku could do was pathetically attempt to defend himself – or, sometimes, others – from Kacchan's unjustified anger. He would cry and shake and his voice would crack more often than not, but he would still *try*. Of course, before he inherited One For All, there wasn't much he managed to do, and Kacchan would end up either giving him a beating or scolding him so hard his words hurt more than his fists. Izuku supposed that was the reason why he always felt so tired after their conflicts – the emotional toll Kacchan's abuse used to take on him was too heavy for him to bear.

After he made himself stronger and more confident about himself, Kacchan's words still hurt, but not in the same way they used to. Whereas Izuku felt fear and pain back in the days he was a wimpy, defenseless nerd, now he could only feel grief whenever Kacchan was unnecessarily mean to him. Grief for what they used to have, before Kacchan's quirk manifested and an uncrossable bridge appeared between himself and Izuku alongside it; grief for what they could have had if he had been born with a quirk of his own or if Kacchan's parents had managed to control their son before his head grew too much. Either way, Izuku felt tired whenever there was conflict between himself and Kacchan – if before he felt tired because of his fear, now he felt tired because of his sorrow.

Kacchan's words fueled his desire to become number 1, too, but Izuku couldn't deny that their main effect was *hurting* him.

Still, as his eyelids parted and he instinctively stretched his shoulders, he rejoiced on how well-rested he felt. His back no longer ached, his muscles were relaxed and he felt a renewed energy inside him.

Then he felt something on his head.

Slowly turning to look what was touching his scalp, Izuku found himself baffled at the realization that it was Kacchan's hand.

He couldn't see Kacchan's face, as it was buried in one of the many pillows that made up the fort he built, but his hand and half his arm had reached across the tall fortress of pillows and his fingers were tangled in Izuku's hair, as if he had fallen asleep in the middle of playing with his curls. Izuku froze, not sure of what to do in this type of situation. He was sure it must have been an accident, but he was also sure that, if Kacchan woke up and found his

hand in Izuku's hair, he would certainly find a way to put the blame on *stupid Deku* or whatever it was he felt like calling Izuku on that day.

He didn't know why his heart was racing so fast at the discovery, but what he did know was that he should get out of that situation before Kacchan woke up.

Izuku moved slowly, carefully, in order not to wake Kacchan up (because of course he was still asleep; there was no way in hell he would voluntarily bury his hand in Izuku's hair while he was *awake*), gently removing himself from Kacchan's touch and sitting up on the bed. He was surprised when the mattress didn't rattle with his movements, but then he remembered he was a ghost, and he couldn't really interact with anything or anyone other than Kacchan.

It didn't really make sense that his back needed a soft surface for him to sleep on, but his weight and his form didn't interact with the mattress in any way. How could he touch something without being able to change it? Izuku sighed as he got to his feet. The quirk he had been hit with was truly remarkable, and way more mysterious than he liked.

He wanted to speak to All Might in private, to have a conversation with his mentor without anyone else present. He wanted to ask about the investigation, about how close they were to catching the villain – but he knew that there was no way to communicate with anyone without Kacchan's intervening. And All Might wouldn't be able to answer any of Kacchan's questions, even if they were coming from Izuku – that would be breaking protocol. All Might was often willing to break protocol for Izuku – not that either of them would ever admit it –, but breaking it for Kacchan was an entirely different story.

Despite of Kacchan's reassurance that he wouldn't allow Izuku to die, he couldn't help but to worry about Aizawa sensei's words from their last reunion. *Especially when another student's life is on the line*. What had he meant by that? Was his life in risk? Was that why he was feeling more tired with each passing day? Uraraka and Iida had said his body wasn't looking so good, and even though Kacchan had been trying to make him more comfortable, he wasn't… feeling so good, either.

Maybe he just missed his mom. She always knew how to make him feel better. She always had the right thing to say, the right place to touch, the right way to hug him. Izuku wished he could see her. Maybe then she would be able to help him with the tiring, heavy sadness that sad deep in his chest.

He sat by the window and stared outside, watching as UA came to life with the rising sun. None of their friends were up yet – Izuku suspected Kacchan was always the first one to wake up –, but it was nice watching the way everything gained color and the birds begin to chirp. It was nice to see how the world kept turning, even though his body was stuck to a hospital bed with no prospect to wake up. It was nice.

It also made him feel ridiculously small, but he didn't really mind.

It didn't take too long for Kacchan to wake up, growling low in his throat with a hoarse voice and shifting on the bed. Izuku didn't turn to look at him as the boy stretched and sighed, but his head soon perked up above the pillow tower, looking around the room and finding Izuku

sat by the window. His hair was messy in a way that could have been described as adorable, if this wasn't Kacchan he was talking about.

Kacchan didn't bid him good morning, talk to him, or even acknowledge him at all. He simply sat up, stretched some more, got to his feet and headed to the bathroom, closing the door behind him.

Izuku sighed, leaning his head on the window frame and watching the birds that were flying away in the distance. He knew that the wind was blowing, but he couldn't really feel it.

He didn't move from his spot by the window as Kacchan returned and began to dress himself for class. Izuku could see him change clothes through his peripheral vision, but stayed where he was. As he had done on the previous day, Kacchan gathered his material and placed everything he would need inside his backpack, but, unlike Izuku had expected, he sat by his studying desk, instead of heading out. Izuku frowned.

"Kacchan?", Izuku asked, looking at him for the first time ever since he woke up. Kacchan didn't look at him, simply opening the two notebooks he had been using in the previous night and grabbing his pencil so that he could take notes. Upon his lack of response, Izuku shifted so that he could look at Kacchan better. "What are you doing?"

"Take a fucking guess", Katsuki bit angrily, not looking at Izuku.

Oh. So they were back to their usual banter, if that could be even called as such. Izuku leaned over and tried to see what Katsuki was doing from up close, trying his best to hide his disappointment at the unnecessary aggression. He had thought at least… *something* would change after their conversation from the previous night. Kacchan had promised he would try to be better, after all.

Upon Izuku's analytical silence, and probably also remembering his promise, Katsuki continued, still sounding grumpy but not as much as before:

"I'm going to finish this before we go to the damn class".

"I thought you wanted to arrive first", Izuku commented, focusing on reading the content of the notebooks. There seemed to be a mix of notes on the pages – the neat ones were certainly from Yaoyorozu, whereas the messy ones could be from any of Kacchan's friends. Izuku figured Kirishima must have stopped by at some point on the previous day, probably when he was still asleep, to deliver the notes.

"From the shit that's been going down for the past few days, I think it's pretty safe to say the universe doesn't give a rat's ass about what I *want*", Katsuki said grumpily, continuing to write. Izuku opted not to respond, and instead continued to read both Kirishima and Yaoyorozu's notes, as well as the ones Kacchan was currently taking. This was probably the only way he would be able to get in touch with their studies while he was trapped out of his body.

Katsuki hadn't been lying in the previous day when he said he had been almost done with studying before they went to the common room. Less than twenty minutes passed before he

was finished with his notes, closing the notebooks and shoving them inside his backpack before standing up and throwing it over his shoulder. He didn't indicate for Izuku to follow him or shot any other bitter remark at him – instead, he simply made his way to the door, put his shoes on by the doorframe and walked out, holding the door open for Izuku as he always did.

Izuku sighed, but followed. Kacchan was acting weird.

It was only expectable that their relationship got even more turbulent after their messy discussion from the previous day – Izuku had been painfully honest, finally mustering the courage (and the anger, even if the feeling had been Kacchan's, and not his) to speak of truths which he hadn't dared approach until then. Of course, everything must have been a bit shocking to Kacchan – he was used to Izuku shaking and trembling in fear beneath him, not *talking back* to him and throwing painful accusations on his face.

Izuku had expected Kacchan to be angry. After all, they had finally talked about the day when he told Izuku to kill himself – Izuku had *shoved it on his face*. He had accused him and admitted to all the pain Kacchan had ever made him feel. Not only that – he had *made* Kacchan feel his *pain*, even if it hadn't been his intention. If Kacchan wasn't going to change, Izuku had expected him to at least be angry, furious, or more bitter than usual.

But he was just – quiet. Apart from the few grumpy statements he had offered Izuku while he was studying, he hadn't said anything else. From the way he was walking five steps ahead of Izuku with his hands shoved in his pockets and his shoulders hunched over, he didn't look like he was about to start conversation, either.

Huh. Weird.

"Hey, Kacchan", Izuku called, rushing his footsteps in order to keep up with Katsuki. He was concerned, but he also wanted to test whether Kacchan would respond as he normally would. "You okay?"

Silence. They began to descend the stairs.

"You're acting a bit weird", he insisted, walking alongside Kacchan.

More silence. They walked out of the dorm building.

Izuku frowned, all thoughts about testing responses evaporating from his mind. Something was definitely not right. His concern overwhelmed any other feeling, and thoughts about tests were obliterated from his mind.

"Seriously, Kacchan. Is everything all right?"

Silence. Izuku sighed.

"Is this about yesterday?"

He started to feel angry – a possible sign that he was probably annoying Kacchan. But he needed to know.

“Just tell me what it is. I know you’re angry, but I don’t know why”.

“Tch”.

“*Kacchan*”.

Silence.

“If you’re going to be like that, then *fine*”, Izuku ended up spitting out before he could think better about it, angry. It was only after he spoke the words that he realized he hadn’t meant them, but he was feeling too angry and irritated to take them back.

Was that how Kacchan felt all the time?

They walked the rest of the way to the classroom in silence, Izuku allowing himself to fall back again and walking a few steps behind Katsuki. When they walked in, Todoroki, Iida, and Uraraka, as well as Yao-Momo and Jirou were already there. They seemed surprised to see Katsuki arrive after them for what was possibly the first time ever. Katsuki, on the other hand, didn’t look at any of them as he made his way to his assigned seat, but Izuku stared at his friends with longing and sorrow, wishing desperately to be seen and feeling bad that he couldn’t be.

He spared a glimpse at Katsuki, noticing he was already on his seat with his notebook open in front of him. His friends had bid him good morning, to which he responded with a simple huff and a nod. Izuku didn’t feel like taking his assigned seat behind Kacchan just yet, but he also felt weird walking away from Kacchan to be with his friends. First, because his friends couldn’t see him, so it would be weird and probably a little creepy if Izuku just stood beside them listening to their conversation. Second, Kacchan had been his sole companion for the past days. For some reason, it felt like betrayal to choose other people’s company rather than his, even if he was being an ass to Izuku. Being an ass was just Kacchan’s modus operandi, right?

Izuku’s eyes darted between Kacchan, who was sitting in silence with his back turned to him, and his group of friends, who were gathered at the back of the room speaking in a low voice. He bit his lower lip, trying to make a choice. His eyes found Kacchan again. Kacchan didn’t look at him, or even seemed to remember he was there in the first place.

Fine. It couldn’t hurt to just hang around his friends for a little while, right?

Izuku approached his friends slowly, even though there was no reason to – they couldn’t see or hear him. Yao-Momo and Jirou had left their assigned seats in order to listen to Iida’s and Uraraka’s conversation, whereas Todoroki was on his assigned seat, from where he could still participate if he wanted to (even if he didn’t look like he wanted to).

“I mean, he does look more tired with each passing day”, Yao-Momo was saying with a concerned look on her face. “If Tokoyami-kun is right –“

“Let’s hope he’s not”, Jirou intervened, bearing a neutral face. Izuku could still see the concern in her eyes.

“We should talk to Aizawa sensei about this”, Yao-Momo continued, nervous. “I’m concerned about them. Especially since last night. We all heard their discussion in the kitchen. Even if Bakugou talked to us afterwards, and delivered Midoriya’s message…”

“If we talk to Aizawa sensei, Bakugou-kun will explode us into little pieces”, Uraraka commented, sparing the subject of their conversation a hesitant look, as if she wanted to make sure Katsuki hadn’t overheard her. Her usual cheeriness was absent from her face.

Izuku frowned. What were they talking about?

“I believe Kirishima-kun has spoken to Bakugou about the subject”, Iida intervened.

“Yeah, but he didn’t *believe* him”, Jirou pointed out. “Said he was fine. You know how he is”.

“*We* know how he is, but this doesn’t mean anything”, Uraraka said, looking like she had made a choice. “We can’t just let them… *do this* because Bakugou is stubborn. We have to do something”, she looked at Yao-Momo. “I agree with you. I think we should talk to Aizawa sensei, even if Bakugou-kun does blow us up”.

“We can speak to him after class”, Yao-Momo nodded, still looking worried. “After Bakugou has left. I think it’s better if he isn’t present at the time”.

What are they talking about? Why are they so worried? What will they tell Aizawa sensei?

“I cannot say I agree with leaving Bakugou in the dark about this, especially since it is such a personal subject”, Iida frowned. “But if he is being so stubborn and Midoriya’s life may be in danger because of this…”

What?

“… then I will go with you to speak to Aizawa sensei”.

“It’s not just Midoriya’s life”, Jirou corrected. “It’s Bakugou’s, as well. He’s wasting away”.

Izuku turned to look at Katsuki. He was sitting in the same position, hunched over and silent. He frowned.

“What do you think, Todoroki-kun?”, Uraraka leaned forwards on her chair so that she could take a look at Todoroki, whose view was blocked by Yao-Momo and Jirou sitting in front of him. Upon the call of his name, he turned to look at Uraraka, his face as neutral as ever. “You are the one who has been visiting Deku-kun the most! And we know how attentive you are to these kind of details. Do you think Tokoyami-kun’s theory is right?”, Uraraka elaborated.

What is this theory? What are they talking about?

“I don’t believe I’m qualified to say whether Tokoyami is right or wrong”, Todoroki said, looking pensive. “But I can say Midoriya is looking weaker every day”.

“What about Bakugou?”, Jirou asked, sparing Katsuki a quick glimpse as if to make sure he wasn’t overhearing their whispered conversation, just like Uraraka had done a few moments

before.

“He’s looking better than before, I believe. But still, more worn out than his usual. Maybe having two souls attached to his body is taking its toll on him”, Todoroki commented. Izuku’s eyes widened.

Was that what they thought? That Kacchan was getting weaker and tired because he was being forced to carry Izuku around as well? Was that what they were going to tell Aizawa sensei?

“Kirishima-kun said he’s been trying to be nicer to Deku-kun, so maybe there’s been improvement in both sides”, Uraraka said, frowning. “And, until yesterday, I hadn’t expected Bakugou-kun to just tell us about Deku-kun’s feelings like that. Maybe spending time together is being good for Bakugou-kun, but… Still…”, she hesitated, biting his lower lip. “We need to find this villain soon”.

“Yeah”, Jirou agreed, looking mournful. “I don’t like it that Midoriya’s soul has been disconnected from his body for so long. This can’t be healthy”.

“I don’t like it that the teachers aren’t telling us anything, either”, Yao-Momo complemented, hugging herself. “They should at least let Midoriya’s friends know how close they are to helping him get better”.

“Maybe they aren’t”, Todoroki added ominously. All eyes turned towards him. “Close to helping him”, he clarified sternly. “Maybe that is why they aren’t telling us anything”.

“That is a severe lack of faith in the competence of our school, Todoroki-kun!”, Iida reprimanded vehemently.

“It’s the truth”, Todoroki continued, unfaltering in the face of Iida’s disapproval and picking at one of his nails with apparent indifference. “UA has been receiving daily criticism from the media for the several disasters that took place ever since we began studying here. First, an attack inside their private quarters, then Bakugou getting kidnapped by the villains… You would think they would want to reassure the public and the media about Midoriya’s condition as soon as they could, and that is what they have been doing. However, we are seeing no results, only promises. Even if they say they are close to a capture in the news, Midoriya is still wasting away in a hospital bed. That indicates that they are desperate to maintain their image, but nowhere close to arresting the villain who did this. If they were, they wouldn’t waste so much time giving interviews and making press conferences – they would be busy working on a capture”.

Everyone fell silent. Iida lowered his head. Izuku felt himself grow pale.

“Perhaps making Aizawa sensei, and thus the board of teachers of the UA, aware that Bakugou is becoming overloaded by the connection he shares with Midoriya, we can force their hand into working harder on a capture rather than focusing on their publicity”, Todoroki concluded stoically.

“You really think Aizawa sensei is more worried about publicity?”, Yao-Momo turned towards Todoroki. There was no malice or judgement in her tone, only sincere curiosity.

“No”, Todoroki replied without missing a beat. “But Principal Nezu certainly is, and he is the one responsible for making the decisions”.

Everyone fell silent again.

“Well”, Iida broke the silence after a few moments. “It is settled, then. After class, we will speak to Aizawa sensei and inform him of our concerns regarding Bakugou’s well-being”.

“And Deku-kun’s”, Uraraka added, even though she didn’t really have to.

More of their friends were arriving and the class was almost full. With the increasing number of people who could end up overhearing their conversation, his friends fell silent and the subject was concluded. Izuku decided to make his way back to his own assigned seat, a blank, almost frightened look on his face as he took his chair.

Was he… Was he overloading Kacchan? By simply being there? Was Izuku putting Kacchan’s life on the line along with his own by being attached to his soul?

Was he… Was he *harming* Kacchan?

He thought back to the previous day, to the terrifying image of Kacchan crying and his voice breaking just because Izuku was feeling a little sad. He thought back to how utterly tired he had felt after their argument in the kitchen, and how Kacchan had looked exhausted as well. He thought back to the way Kacchan only walked and sat with hunched shoulders, instead of his usual straight-back, better-than-you stance – almost as if he was carrying the weight of the world on his shoulders.

In a way, he was. He was carrying a whole *life* on his shoulders.

Was Izuku draining him like a parasite? Was he making Kacchan waste away? Was he *killing* Kacchan?

“Cut that out”, Katsuki muttered without turning to look at Izuku, who was sitting behind him. Izuku raised his head abruptly, surprised by the sudden interaction.

“W-What?”, he asked, confused.

“You’re fucking mumbling again”, was Katsuki’s simple response over his shoulder. Izuku fell silent and Katsuki went back to reading through his notes. Aizawa sensei would arrive any moment now.

“Kacchan”, Izuku called, concerned. If there really was a chance he was hurting Kacchan, he needed to let him know. Katsuki didn’t respond, so he leaned over his desk and whispered on his ear with urgency: “*Kacchan*”.

“*Told you* not to talk to me in public”, Katsuki growled low, turning his head slightly towards Izuku and speaking through gritted teeth. “Don’t want anyone thinking I’m a *nutcase*”.

“Is that why you weren’t talking to me before?”, Izuku frowned. “But wait, you weren’t talking to me as well back in the bedroom, where no one could see you, so that can’t be it, can it? If that was the only problem, there would be no reason for you to ignore me when we were alone, so the nutcase –“

“*Cut. That. Out*.”, Katsuki growled again, managing to sound more dangerous this time.

“S-Sorry”, Izuku apologized, sincere. “But I want to ask you something”.

“Save it for when we’re not in a room full of people and when I’m actually in the mood to put up with your shit”, was Katsuki’s whispered response. *There goes his promise to try and be better*, Izuku thought, taking a deep breath.

“But it’s serious”, Izuku added.

“I don’t give a fuck. Now shut up”, Katsuki huffed. Izuku shrunk on himself.

He hesitated for a second before mustering his courage and taking a deep breath.

“Do you think I’m killing you?”, he asked in a small voice, sounding almost shy and apologetic. For some reason, that seemed to be enough to catch Katsuki’s attention in a way that none of his other attempts had, because he immediately turned on his seat, looking at Izuku with suspicious, narrowed, sharp eyes. All conversation in the classroom died, since everyone realized Katsuki was interacting with an invisible Izuku. *They’re probably thinking he’s going to freak out like yesterday*, Izuku realized.

Instead of freaking out, Katsuki stood up from his seat abruptly, grabbing Izuku’s forearm and dragging him out of the classroom, royally ignoring all the eyes that were glued on him. Once he was outside, he shut the door close behind him, even though Aizawa sensei hadn’t arrived yet. He shoved Izuku against the wall and crossed his arms above his chest, a no-shit expression on his face.

“All right. Talk”, he instructed aggressively. Izuku blinked blankly, taken aback by the sudden development of actions.

“I – I don’t –“, he stuttered nervously. Katsuki sighed and rolled his eyes.

“You obviously overheard something you shouldn’t have when you were eavesdropping on your shitty friends’ conversation like a creepy son of a bitch”, Katsuki pointed out, earning a blush from Izuku. “So *talk*. The fuck did those bastards say that got you so worried?”

“I’m – I’m not sure they want you to k-know –“, Izuku tried to say, only to have Katsuki angrily place one of his hands on the wall directly beside his head, pinning him and preventing him from walking away.

“Too late”, he barked. “You already came to me with that nonsense, so you might as well spill it”.

Izuku stared up at Katsuki, noticing the slight purplish tinge beneath his eyes and the way his shoulders were hunched. Almost as if guessing that Deku was paying attention to his

tiredness, Katsuki stood up straighter and took in a deep breath, getting a hold of himself.

“If you don’t *tell* me, shitty Deku”, he said in a low, threatening voice, leaning closer to Izuku and pressing him harder against the wall. “Imma walk right back in and ask your shitty friends all about it, whatever it is. And I’ll make sure to let them know *you* were the fucking snitch, since you were *eavesdropping* on them”, he smirked victoriously upon the frightened look that overcame Izuku’s face. The fear was soon replaced by indignation.

“I wasn’t eavesdropping”, Izuku protested, but the defense sounded weak to his own ears.

“Yeah?”, Katsuki scoffed. “So what do you call listening to a conversation you weren’t invited to, without anyone knowing you’re listening in the first place?”

Izuku’s mouth opened and closed several times as he tried to come up with a response, making him look like a fish out of water. Katsuki scoffed again and shook his head.

“Just tell me about it, fucker. If you didn’t want me to know, you wouldn’t have asked me what you did”, he pointed out. Izuku lowered his head and sighed in defeat.

“They want to talk to Aizawa sensei after class”, Izuku said, not meeting Katsuki’s eyes. “They think – uh… They think you’re overloaded. B-Because of… me. Because you have two souls attached to you”, he concluded sadly, lifting his gaze to meet Kacchan’s eyes with an apologetic look. Katsuki’s face paled considerably, which made Izuku frown.

Realization dawned on him.

“Did you know that, Kacchan?”, Izuku asked, a mixture of worry and an accusation hidden in his tone. Katsuki averted his eyes from him, looking grumpy. Izuku grabbed one of Katsuki’s wrists before he could turn away. “*Kacchan*. Did you know that?”, he asked seriously. How could Kacchan have known something like that and not *told* him?!

“Don’t fucking *grab* me like that; who do you think you are?”, Katsuki asked angrily, yanking his hand away from Izuku’s grasp. Izuku didn’t have the time to feel sad at the sharp statement – all he could feel was anger – all-consuming, overwhelming anger. He couldn’t tell whether it was coming from Kacchan or from himself.

“How could you not *tell* me about it?! You knew I’m harming you and you said *nothing*?!”, he accused, his voice coming out louder than he had intended. In all honesty, Izuku wasn’t used to having angry outbursts – those were Kacchan’s area of expertise, not his. Katsuki glared at him.

“You’re not fucking *harming* me, dipshit”, Katsuki said, running a tired hand across his face before shoving his hands into his pockets. “Don’t believe anything you hear just because it was one of your stupid friends who said it”.

“So you knew!”, Izuku accused again, upset. Katsuki rolled his eyes. Weirdly enough, he didn’t seem to be as angry as Izuku was feeling.

It had been the same when Izuku felt sad before. Katsuki had ended up dealing with most of the sadness, while Izuku only felt a mild discomfort. Now, Izuku was feeling most of the anger, whereas Katsuki only felt mild annoyance. It was an uncanny exchange.

“Look”, Katsuki said as patiently as he could, still rolling his eyes. “Kirishima stopped by yesterday to lend me the notebook. The one I was studying today”, he shrugged. “He mentioned the dumbass theory bird-brain had come up with, but there was no point telling you because it’s *not* fucking true”.

“But it *makes sense*”, Izuku protested, cutting in. “You couldn’t have just kept something like that from me –“

“Oh my god, *shut the fuck up*!”, Katsuki shouted. The anger was drained from Izuku so fast that it made him dizzy, and it appeared to have gone all the way back to Kacchan. “I can keep whatever the *fuck* I want from you, you bastard! Stop thinking you can tell me what to do!”

“It’s *my soul* we’re talking about!”, Izuku half-shouted. “It’s *your* body! Any information you decide to keep from me could result on both of us dying –“

“That’s not fucking happening –“

“You should have *told* me about it, Kacchan!”

“What for, huh?”, Katsuki exploded. “For you to bitch and moan at me like you’re doing right now? For you to keep whining like the pathetic asshole you are? For you to spend the entire fucking day sobbing on me because of this shit? Ok, now you know, Deku. There’s a chance you’re draining my fucking lifeforce away with every little breath your shitty soul takes. What are you gonna do, huh? Are you going to detach yourself from me, now? Are you gonna find a way to shove yourself back into your body? What the *fuck* are you gonna do?”, he shoved Izuku hard, making the boy’s back collide with the wall behind him. Katsuki felt the impact too, and finally realized what he had done – and how hard he had lost his cool.

Izuku stared up at him with big, wide, tearful eyes that were accompanied by a wobbly lip. *Great*. He was going to fucking cry again?

Why wasn’t Katsuki crying too, then?

He supposed he was too angry for crying. Had their feelings evened out?

No, there was a deep, smothering feeling squeezing his chest and giving him pain. He was feeling Deku’s sadness. Suddenly, he didn’t feel in the mood to be angry anymore.

“I didn’t fucking tell you about it because there’s nothing you can do”, Katsuki continued, the words coming out through gritted teeth as he did his best not to lose his temper. “There’s nothing *I* can do, either. We don’t even know if that theory is right. For all I know, we could be feeling so fucking exhausted because you keep having those stupid emotional breakdowns all the time and they’re *fucking* tiring me out. Either way, it doesn’t really matter if you’re draining my energy”, he snorted. Izuku frowned.

“It… doesn’t?”, he asked hesitantly.

“No, it *doesn’t*, stupid Deku”, he scowled. “Because – and I can’t fucking believe I’m about to say this shit to you –, until we find a way to put you back where you belong, you ain’t going *anywhere*. You hear me?”, he stared at Izuku with intense eyes, as if to show him he was being serious.

Izuku, for one, didn’t know what to say or how to react, so he simply stared up at Katsuki, eyes wide and confused. For all the name-calling and abuse he insisted on giving Izuku, even in his soul-like state, he seemed pretty keen on not allowing him to die.

Maybe it was guilt – after all, Izuku was only in this situation because he had saved Katsuki from the villain’s attack. Maybe it really had to do with wanting to be better than Izuku when they became heroes. Maybe it was something else, something that Izuku couldn’t quite name. Either way, one thing he could tell for sure – Kacchan’s eyes were sincere, as were his words. Izuku nodded, deciding to trust the boy’s confidence – if there was one thing in the world that was unfaltering, it was Kacchan’s trust in himself.

“What were you even going to do anyway, you piece of shit?”, Katsuki scoffed, shoving Deku away in an almost playful manner after the boy agreed with his words. “You can’t get rid of me that easily”.

“Bakugou”, a voice called from behind them. Katsuki startled, not having heard anyone approach them, and turned around only to find Aizawa sensei standing in the middle of the hallway, intense gaze fixed on him. He couldn’t tell how long the teacher had been there, or how much of the conversation he had heard.

If he had listened to anything, he didn’t show. Instead of saying anything else or even scolding Bakugou for not being inside the classroom and waiting for him, Aizawa sensei simply stepped closer to him, an intrigued look on his face.

“How is your concussion?”, he asked, sounding genuinely interested, even though his face had an extreme opposite expression.

“Better”, Katsuki responded, staring back at his teacher with a similarly intense look. “Sensei”, he added politely as an afterthought, after a few seconds of delay and a meaningful nudge from Izuku.

“So I’m correct to assume you’re not about to blow up anymore of my class’s furniture today?”, Aizawa sensei raised an eyebrow at him, a knowing look on his face.

“That was an accident”, Katsuki lowered his head with a grumpy look, feeling embarrassed but not willing to go into any more details. Aizawa sensei stared at him for a few more seconds before stepping aside.

“Don’t take too long to go inside”, he instructed, not looking at Katsuki and reaching for the door handle. “Your current situation does not give you a free pass to do whatever you want”.

“Sensei”, Katsuki called before Aizawa managed to open the door, a serious look on his face. His teacher turned his head to look at him, and he took a deep, calming breath deeply before continuing. “After class, some of my friends will talk to you. Don’t listen to them”, he said, hoping that Aizawa sensei would manage to catch the seriousness – and the sanity – behind his gaze. “They don’t know what they’re saying”, he concluded.

Aizawa sensei stared at him as if trying to read him like a book. He didn’t nod, shake his head, or give Katsuki any sort of indication that he had heard his request before opening the door and walking inside the classroom.

“Kacchan”, Izuku grabbed Katsuki’s wrist again before the boy could follow their teacher inside the room. The door clicked closed quietly behind Aizawa sensei, leaving the two boys standing outside. This time, Katsuki didn’t shrug away from Izuku’s touch, waiting for him to continue instead. “I don’t think it’s such a bad idea for them to talk to Aizawa sensei”, Izuku said, looking serious and concerned. “If the theory is true –“

“It’s *not* true”, Katsuki cut him short.

“ – if it *is*”, Izuku continued. “I don’t want to risk your life”.

“And you’ll do what? Just walk off and die?”, Katsuki snorted a humorless laugh, mocking. Izuku continued to stare at him with a serious look, neither agreeing nor denying. For some reason, this pissed Katsuki off beyond compare and he snarled. Was the nerd really considering allowing himself to *die* just so that he could save Katsuki?

That wouldn’t be a first, though.

Katsuki growled in anger at the thought. He yanked himself away from Izuku’s grasp again.

“That’s not fucking happening”, he spat bitterly, never meeting Izuku’s eyes.

“Why would you put your life on the line like that for *me*?”, Izuku asked, genuine confusion evident in his frowning face. He still sounded a bit angry, but more lost than anything.

“I could ask you the same fucking question”, was all he said before shoving the door to their classroom open and walking in, giving Izuku had the time to protest. All the boy could do was follow.

“I swear to god, you’re becoming more unbearable with each passing day”.

“It’s not my fault we missed so many classes!”

“Actually, it *is*, shitty Deku”.

“I thought we’d gotten over that. I *saved your life*”.

“No, you fucking didn’t. And stop trying to shove it on my face”.

“Anyway, I still have way too many questions. Are you sure we can’t stop by Aizawa sensei’s office after lunch? I just need you to ask him a couple questions about quirk th–“

“I told you that’s not fucking happening. You already mumbled way too many questions in my ear during the fucking class and made me look like a stupid idiot. Now shut the fuck up before I shove a sock down your throat”.

A pause.

“… Do you think you could do that?”

“I’m pretty sure I already did at some point of our lives”.

“No, I mean. In my current state. Do you think you’d manage to shove a sock down my throat while I’m like… this?”

Katsuki looked at him.

“Are you saying you want me to try?”

Silence.

“You’re such a fucking weirdo, Deku”.

“I’m just saying it would be interesting to know!”

“You’re basically just saying you want my sock down your throat. That’s weird as *fuck*”.

“It doesn’t have to be *your* sock! It could be anyone’s sock! I actually think it would be better if we tried several different socks for better results”.

“Get the hell away from me, you creep”.

“I mean it! I’ve been thinking a lot about it, actually”.

“About my sock?”

“About touching things. So far, I know I can touch you, and your bed, and your pillows. I didn’t manage to touch anything else from your room, but when I touch you, I can feel your clothes. Is it because the clothes are on you? Or would I manage to touch them if you’re not wearing them? I wanted to try, but I couldn’t open your wardrobe because my hand kept phasing through it”,

“You tried to *open my fucking wardrobe*?!”

“For *research purposes*, Kacchan!”

“I’m going to *fucking* kill you!”

“Aren’t you curious to know?!”

“I’ll kill you!”

“I mean, what is the limit to what objects I can touch and interact with? I can sleep on your bed and I can lean my head on a pillow –“

“Fucking mumbling son of a bitch –“

“ – but I can’t move it or grab it, for example. I can sit on places if I want to, but I can’t actually move anything. If you’re unconscious, would I be able to drag you?”

“Deku, for fuck’s sake –“

“What would it look like to other people? Can I only move you when you’re awake?”

“Stop. Fucking. Talking. About it. It’s fucking *weird*”.

“Don’t act like you don’t want to know, too”.

“Fine. You want a sock down your throat? You want a fucking sock down your throat so *bad*??!!”

“Uh… Bakugou?”

Katsuki snapped his head to the side to find Kirishima, Kaminari, Mina, and Sero standing in front of him, all of them bearing similar expressions on their faces. They were holding trays with their lunches, but Mina’s was shaking really bad from the way she was trying to keep herself from laughing.

Katsuki took into consideration what that scene may have looked like to them. Katsuki, sitting (apparently) by himself at one of the lunch tables, his food untouched in front of him. Him, reaching across the table and grabbing an invisible shirt that belonged to an invisible nerd, shouting threats about socks in throats in the middle of lunch while his other hand popped with tiny explosions. He probably looked more like a lunatic than he would like to admit.

“The fuck are you all looking at?”, Katsuki asked, letting go of Deku, who fell heavily against the chair without moving it out of place. *Fine*, maybe it would actually be interesting to investigate what objects Deku could or couldn’t touch. Fuck the damn nerd and his contagious curiosity.

“Nothing”, Sero said. His face was serious, but Katsuki could tell he wanted to laugh. “You were just… uh…”

“Shouting about socks. In the middle of the hall”, Kaminari concluded. Mina barely managed to keep it together and emitted a high-pitched whine as she failed to hold back laughter.

“Yeah. And what is it to you?”, Katsuki replied angrily, unwilling to admit that the scene he had made must have been weird as hell to outside viewers. “Don’t like it, go find somewhere else to sit”, he growled, starting to eat his food.

His friends sat down in silence at his table, all of them exchanging looks among themselves. Only after they were all settled did Katsuki look up at Izuku, who had a half-apologetic, half-amused look on his face.

“The fuck are you laughing at?”, Katsuki asked him, angry, forgetting his unwillingness to speak to Deku in front of other people. Deku’s insolence always managed to make him lose his temper. He thought he could mock Katsuki for losing his temper? When *he* was the one who pissed him off in the first place? “Stay in your lane, nerd”, he warned.

“Sorry”, Izuku smiled nervously, looking like it was taking all of his self-control not to burst into laughter. “But… Are we trying the sock theory later?”

“Don’t call it *that*”, Katsuki growled while he chewed his food.

“You shouldn’t speak with your mouth full, Kacchan”.

“You shouldn’t shove your nose on other people’s businesses, *Deku*”.

“But are we doing it later?”

“Fine. Can’t say I won’t be pleased to shove a sock down your fucking throat”.

“Ok, what *is* it, man?”, Kirishima interrupted their conversation, looking conflicted. Facing him, Katsuki found a similar look on each of his friends’ faces. “What is it about the sock?”

“Yeah, bro. We can only hear your side of the conversation, and it’s weird out of context”, Sero nodded his head.

“Is it a weird sex metaphor?”, Kaminari asked with a perverted look, making Katsuki’s face immediately scrunch up and his eyes widen in rage.

“*What the fuck did you just say*? Get the hell out of my table, you sick weirdo!”, he shouted, furious. Izuku blushed violently.

“You’re the one who keeps talking about socks and throats!”, Kaminari protested, sounding frightened. Katsuki stood up.

“*OUT*”, he shouted. Kaminari only had the time to flinch, grab his tray and stand up before Katsuki’s hands popped with tiny explosions. He didn’t look back as he took a seat in a faraway table with Mineta and Shoji.

“Ok”, Kirishima continued when Katsuki sat back down. “But what *is* it about the sock?”

“None of any of your damn businesses”, Katsuki grumbled angrily, continuing to eat his food and not looking at Deku.

They managed to eat in silence for a while, Mina and Sero talking about something Katsuki didn’t bother paying attention to while Kirishima alternated between making a comment here and there in their conversation and looking at Katsuki with worry. Izuku, on the other hand, remained very silent after Kaminari’s comment, getting lost in thought again and staring off at the distance while Katsuki ate.

“But I do want to know whether or not I can touch your clothes once they’re off your body”, he commented absentmindedly, probably not thinking Katsuki would hear him. Katsuki tightened his hands into fists and snarled.

“*Stop saying it like that*”, he growled as lowly as he could, not meaning to draw his friends’ attention. “It’s fucking weird”.

“S-S-Sorry”, Izuku said, remembering his own embarrassment. “I didn’t mean to”.

“*Whatever*, just shut the fuck up”, he growled. It didn’t take him too long to finish his food after Deku shut his mouth, and, as soon as he did, he stood up unceremoniously.

“Hey, Bakubro!”, Kirishima called as soon as Katsuki got on his feet. “Where are you going?”

“Yeah, man! We haven’t talked in so long!”, Sero protested.

“I talked more than enough with you lot last night”, Katsuki grumbled, grabbing his backpack and walking away without a second glance. He didn't see Izuku's disappointed glance.

“So, Kacchan”, Izuku said, going back to his ramble-y mode as soon as they were away from people – and, more precisely, Katsuki’s friends. “Are you sure we can’t stop by Aizawa sensei’s office on our way back? I have at least five questions I wanted to ask about today’s lecture and I wanted to get them done with while they’re still fresh on my –“

“You’d said two questions”, Katsuki interrupted him without looking at him.

“Huh?”

“Before. You said it was a couple of questions. Now you’ve upped it to five”, Katsuki pointed out.

“W-Well… I thought… Maybe I could convince you… If there weren’t too many questions…”, Izuku admitted shyly, following Katsuki close on his tracks.

“Fuck, you’re ridiculous”, Katsuki scorned with a scoff. “It doesn’t matter the *number of questions*, Shitty Deku. I’m not asking him your questions and that’s *final*”.

“But Kacchan –“, Izuku tried to protest, but Katsuki cut him short again.

“If you really want to understand it that bad, I can explain it to you later”, he offered. Before Izuku could get sentimental about the unprecedented offer to study with Kacchan, he added: “but *only* if you shut the fuck up about it and get off my ass for the rest of the day. Also, if you ever mention this to anyone, and I mean *anyone*, *ever* –“

“You’ll explode me in some graphic way. I know”, Izuku concluded. “But are you sure you can help me with this, Kacchan?”, he added hesitantly.

“*What*? Don’t patronize me, you fucking idiot, of *course* I fucking can”, he protested angrily. Izuku raised his arms in defeat, showing he meant no harm.

“That’s not what I meant! It’s just you lost as many classes as I did!”, he explained meekly. “I didn’t think you would have caught up already”.

“*Of course* I caught up already; what the fuck do you take me for?”, he scowled. “I’m not stupid like you”.

Izuku tightened his lips and stared at Katsuki with an offended expression.

“Ok. Remember last night when you told me to speak up when you’re being an asshole?”, Izuku asked, balling his hands into fists. “You’re being one right now”.

“I also remember I told you that ‘asshole’ is a swear word. You kiss your mother with that mouth, shitty Deku?”, Katsuki smirked wickedly. Izuku blushed.

“S-Stop it! It’s your fault I keep cursing so much!”, he protested, embarrassed. “If you could stop feeling so *angry* all the time –“

“I wish you’d stop being such a sentimental nerd loser all the time, too, but I ain’t getting what I want, am I?”, Katsuki shouted angrily in the middle of the hall. A few passersby gave him weird looks, since they couldn’t see Izuku, but Katsuki ignored them, shoving his hands in his pockets and looking grumpy. “Also, you’re only supposed to tell me I’m being an asshole when I *don’t know* I’m being one”, he added in a considerably lowered voice.

“*What*? So you were doing it on *purpose*?!”, Izuku exclaimed, which earned an eyeroll from Katsuki.

“The fuck do you think?”, he huffed.

“That’s mean, Kacchan!”

“Tch. You just get way too upset over small things”.

“Calling me stupid isn’t small!”

“It sure as fuck is. I’ve called you worst things”.

“Well, *yes*, but that doesn’t mean you calling – wait”, Izuku frowned, interrupting his own thought process as he realized where they were. In front of them was the door to Aizawa sensei’s office.

Izuku turned to look at Katsuki with admiration, surprise, and gratitude in his eyes, beaming up with excitement. Had Kacchan actually listened to his request? Had he brought him down to Aizawa sensei's office for him to ask him the questions he wanted? Was this Kacchan's attempt to be better showing?

"Don't look so fucking excited", Katsuki said simply, his voice and face as grumpy as ever. "You're waiting outside".

Izuku's face dropped as if he had been punched in the stomach.

"B-But…", Izuku stuttered, confused. "How will you know the questions I want to ask him if I wait outside?"

"That's *not* what we're here for, dipshit", Katsuki sighed with annoyance, turning to face Izuku. "I don't want you meddling with my business this time. Wait outside while I talk to him", he instructed again. Izuku frowned.

"Why? What are you going to tell him?", he asked, allowing his curiosity and worry to take the best of him. His eyes widened. "Is this about Tokoyami-kun's theory?"

"Deku, I'm trying really hard not to punch your teeth in every time you open that damn trap of yours, so *shut the fuck up* before I stop being calm", Katsuki snarled.

"You call that being calm?", Izuku asked in a small voice, frowning, at the same time Katsuki all but pounded at Aizawa sensei's door in a very impolite manner. Their teacher's voice came from inside the room, sounding as bored and stoic as ever and instructing for whoever it was to come in. Katsuki turned to look at Izuku one final time before opening the door, a warning in his eyes.

"If you know what's good for you, you won't come in, you hear me?", he raised his eyebrows at Izuku, sounding threatening. "Unlike your shitty friends, I'm the only one who can tell when you're eavesdropping, so don't even *think* about trying it".

"Kacchan –"

"*Stay here*, Deku".

And before Izuku could say anything else, Katsuki opened the door, stepped inside, and slammed it closed.

Izuku wanted to lean his head against the door and listen; he wanted to phase himself through the wall like Mirio senpai and find out what Kacchan could possibly be so secretive about. He was usually so blatant and honest – more than necessary, most of the time –; Izuku couldn't figure out what could have caused the change in demeanor.

He never denied he was going to talk about Tokoyami-kun's theory. Maybe Kacchan had grown fed up with Izuku's soul using him as life support and decided to ask Aizawa sensei for a way to get rid of him? Maybe Izuku's accusations and angry remarks had hit a bit too close to home and ended up encouraging Kacchan to try and find a solution to separate them

faster? Kacchan had sounded ok before they went to sleep on the previous night – he had even managed to sound *friendly*, something Izuku had never witnessed before! Why, then, was he displaying such a sour mood ever since he woke up? Why did he want to talk to Aizawa sensei alone, why didn't he want Izuku to listen to their conversation? Why was he being so *angry*? His mind was rushing at lightspeed and Izuku was aware he was probably mumbling, but he couldn't bring himself to stop. The only person capable of hearing him wasn't around to tell him to shut up, anyway.

Izuku realized he was scared. He had told Kacchan about his fear of ending up alone in that soul-like state before, but if Kacchan was really trying to get rid of him despite knowing of Izuku's fear… He didn't know what to think about that. He didn't know how to *feel* about that. All he wanted to know was what Kacchan was telling Aizawa sensei, and how much their conversation would affect him.

It felt like an eternity until Kacchan stepped out of their teacher's office, looking as indifferent and as grumpy as ever. He lowered his gaze to find Izuku sitting at the floor right beside the door, an anxious, anticipative look in his eyes as he mumbled to himself. He sighed.

"You have any idea how fucking *hard* it was to speak to Aizawa sensei while you were making me freak out like that?", he complained, starting to walk away and giving Izuku no choice but to follow. Izuku's eyes widened in realization and shame – he had forgotten that they were sharing feelings now, and that he had probably made Kacchan feel all the stages of his own anxious thoughts.

"S-Sorry, Kacchan", Izuku said, catching up with him and bearing a worried look. "I was… I just… I didn't know what you were telling him, so I got nervous".

"Yeah, I could *feel* that, you damn nerd", Katsuki rolled his eyes, not looking at Izuku. "But it was a good thing that you're a wimpy ass loser, after all. Having me lose my shit for no reason in front of sensei helped me build my case".

"Huh?", Izuku frowned, confused. "What are you talking about, Kacchan? What case?"

Katsuki was silent, not looking at Izuku as they made their way back to the student's dorms.

"Kacchan?", Izuku insisted when he received no response. Katsuki remained silent, staring straight ahead and acting as if Izuku wasn't there. Izuku sighed and tried again, curious and nervous. "Kacchan, are you going to tell me?"

More silence. They arrived at the dorm building and made their way up the stairs, Katsuki continuing to ignore him.

They entered Katsuki's bedroom and he unceremoniously removed his uniform coat, his shirt, and then his pants, dropping them in a heap on his bed and turning his back to Izuku so that he could pick up some new clothes from his wardrobe. Izuku did his best not to stare – after all, it would be weird if Kacchan caught him with eyes fixed on his nearly naked form –, so he just sat on the bed and looked at his own knees instead. He suddenly noticed that Kacchan's uniform was sitting right beside him.

Would he be able to touch the fabric, now that it was no longer in contact with Kacchan's body? He spared the boy a wary look, as if to make sure he wouldn't catch him red-handed in his attempt to find out. Seeing Kacchan still had his back turned to him, Izuku slowly reached across the bed so that his fingertips could find the fabric of the uniform –

"Don't you fucking dare, creepy nerd", Katsuki warned without turning to look at him. Izuku flinched and retrieved his hand as if it had been burned, blushing. He didn't know how Kacchan knew what he had been planning to do, but decided not to question him about it – he knew he would probably receive no answer.

"Uh, Kacchan…", Izuku hesitated after a few silent moments of awkwardness. "Are we… going somewhere?", he asked, noticing Katsuki had picked up his jeans and a going-out shirt, instead of the sweatpants he normally used when he didn't plan on leaving the dorm building. Again, he was left in silence as Katsuki put on his black T-shirt before bending over in order to wear his pants. Izuku averted his eyes again.

Katsuki zipped his pants and walked into the bathroom, this time not closing the door behind him as he usually did. Izuku stayed sitting on the bed, taking the opportunity to touch Kacchan's uniform now that he wasn't looking. His hand phased through the material and he sighed in disappointment. So he could only touch the clothes while Kacchan was wearing them.

Kacchan brushed his teeth (Izuku knew because of the way he kept growling and shouting about germs) and washed his face in order to get rid of the tiredness before walking back out. He put on his shoes and stood beside the door, staring at Izuku as if he expected him to simply hop off the bed and follow him like a loyal puppy. Izuku stared back, not moving.

"Are you coming or what?", Katsuki asked after a few moments of silent staring. He sounded annoyed, but Izuku didn't allow that to throw him off his balance.

"Where are we going?", he asked simply, opting to be straightforward rather than passive-aggressive. Katsuki sighed, rolled his eyes, opened the door, and walked out. Izuku was inevitably dragged behind him by the invisible bond that tied them together, yelping in surprise. He had almost forgotten that Kacchan couldn't get too far away from him without bringing him along in the process.

Katsuki waited until Izuku was out of the bedroom before walking back and closing the door behind him. Without sparing the confused boy a single look, he went back on his way across the hall and towards the stairs. Izuku stumbled his way after him.

"Wait, Kacchan! Tell me where we're going!", he asked, having his words ignored again. Izuku's wish was to plant both his feet on the floor and stop Kacchan from walking away as if Izuku was a dog meant to follow him, but they were in the middle of descending the stairs, and if he stopped so abruptly, he could end up making Kacchan fall. Therefore, he followed, a grumpy look overtaking his face and getting mixed with the confusion already etched there.

As soon as they were out of the dorm building and away from any possible curious ears, Katsuki stopped on his tracks and turned to face Izuku with a serious, mildly annoyed look on his face. Izuku froze on his tracks, ears sharp with attention and eyes wide in surprise.

“Listen, shitty nerd”, he said simply, his voice coming out in that usual angry-ish tone that seemed to be a constant for Katsuki. “We’re going out. I don’t want you asking me any questions about it, or we’ll turn the fuck around and go back to the dorm. You’ll understand once we get there. Now shut the hell up and follow me”.

Katsuki’s words were so shocking that Izuku didn’t immediately follow him when he started walking again, which resulted on him being pulled and dragged once Katsuki got too far away. He stumbled and struggled to catch up with the boy again, bearing an even more confused look on his face once he did.

“W-What do you mean, ‘out’, Kacchan?”, he asked, despite of Katsuki’s warning. “Are we allowed to do that? Shouldn’t we stay in UA grounds, especially after the villain attacked us? Kacchan! Kacchan, wait!”, Izuku called after him when his questions went unanswered and Katsuki picked up his pace.

“*Kacchan, Kacchan, Kacchan*, that’s so *fucking* annoying”, Katsuki stopped on his tracks and turned on his heels in order to angrily glare at Izuku. He grabbed one of Izuku’s wrists and dragged him along so that he didn’t fall behind again, resuming his rushed walk towards the main exit of UA grounds. “Use your brain for once in your shitty life and put two and two together”, he scoffed angrily. “The fuck do you think I was talking to Aizawa sensei about?”

Izuku’s face fell in realization.

“Oh”, he said simply, feeling embarrassed about his own obliviousness.

“Yeah. *Oh*”, Katsuki mocked him, rolling his eyes. “Now be quiet and tag along. I’m tired of having to drag your heavy ass around. Don’t make me regret this, shitty Deku”, he warned as they stepped out, letting go of Izuku’s wrist and trusting him to keep up on his own.

No alarms blared and no security tried to stop them as they walked out of the UA as Izuku had expected. His eyes kept darting around with worry and wariness, as if villains were about to jump out of the shadows and attack them any minute now. He did his best to stay quiet as Kacchan had ordered him to, but there were way too many thoughts and questions in his head for him to be able to keep his mouth shut. Five minutes into their walk – towards the train station, as Izuku came to realize –, he broke the silence.

“Are you sure we should be out here, Kacchan?”, he asked nervously, his eyes continuing to dart to any possible places from which villains could emerge throughout the street. Izuku could be many things, but he wasn’t a coward; still, it was always better to be cautious rather than reckless. “I mean, the villain who we fought is still missing, and he – he could be after us. Wherever we are going, I don’t think it’s worth being captured for! Plus, we’re going to miss the afternoon classes –“

“Shut up”, Katsuki interrupted him. “I know what the fuck I’m doing”.

“Yes, I *trust* you, Kacchan”, Izuku clarified, because the last thing he needed was for Katsuki to think he was overestimating him or putting him down again. “But I don’t trust the villain. You’re not even in your battle gear!”

“I don’t fucking *need* my battle gear”, Katsuki scoffed. They arrived at the train station, and Katsuki silently entered the platform without even looking back to see if Izuku was following him. Izuku, on the other hand, hesitated – he wasn’t used to taking the train without paying for his passage. But no one else could see him, or even know that he was there. Before Kacchan could get too far away again, he followed him, phasing through the turnstile and feeling like a criminal.

He silently made his way over to where Kacchan was standing and waiting for the train, a guilty look on his face. Katsuki still wasn’t looking at him. They were silent for several moments.

“What the fuck is it?”, Katsuki ended up asking after a while, feeling the guilt radiating from Izuku – quite literally, in this case, since he could actually feel the guilt. Izuku blushed. “Just spit it out, nerd”, he insisted when he received no response.

“It’s – it’s nothing”, Izuku said simply, turning his face away so that Katsuki wouldn’t be able to see it. Katsuki rolled his eyes so hard he almost managed to see his own brain.

“Listen, dipshit. I’m not one of your melodramatic friends who’s gonna insist on this kind of shit if you put up this shy embarrassed baby act. If I ask you something and you don’t answer it straight away, then boo fucking hoo for you. I don’t have time or patience to waste on *begging you* to talk to me. I’d rather die before I do that”, he scoffed. Izuku lowered his head and bit his lower lip, but stayed silent.

He knew what would happen if he told Kacchan he was feeling guilty because he didn’t pay for his passage. He would never hear the end of it. *You’re a f****** ghost, you sh**** *** loser. Why the f*** would you pay for the f****** passage?*

Their train arrived and they stepped inside silently, not looking at each other. This was the same train they used to take home, back when the UA Heights Alliance didn’t exist. Of course, they never talked to each other – or even looked at each other – when they were in the train together, but they still lived in the same neighborhood, and the way to their homes was still the same. Except Katsuki was always several steps ahead of him, and Izuku never dared approach him.

Now, they were still silent in the train, and still ignoring each other, but at least they weren’t wagons away from each other anymore. They were standing side by side. Izuku supposed that was a small improvement, even if it didn’t feel like much.

We aren’t friends, Deku. We’ll never be. We’re nothing but rivals who happened to get stuck together and now are surviving together. Once you get back to your body, everything will go back to the way it used to be.

Oh, right. He had almost forgotten about that.

Katsuki sighed tiredly at the wave of sadness that must have coursed through him – it sure as hell coursed through Izuku –, but said nothing, standing by his promise that he would never beg Izuku to talk to him. Izuku, on the other hand, simply tried to wave the memories of their

argument away from his mind and concentrate on other things – for example, their destination.

He didn't have the chance to formulate a coherent thought, though, because as soon as the train started moving, he was catapulted out of it.

It only made sense, if he put some effort into understanding. He was a *ghost*. He could stand and sit on places, yes, but he had never tried to find out how his body reacted to breaking inertia. The train started moving, and he didn't have a physical body, anymore – so he simply stayed where he had been standing, and the train moved on without him, having nothing to block him or keep him inside. From Izuku's perspective, he was catapulted out of the train, but the correct assessment would confirm that, in fact, he simply stayed where he was while the train phased through him.

Still, at the loss of the train's flooring, Izuku ended up falling on the tracks and staying behind, while Katsuki remained inside the train, which was moving away without one of them.

Izuku screamed as the bond connecting him to Katsuki didn't allow him to stay behind and started to drag him behind the train, making his back scrape painfully against the floor. He could feel Katsuki was trying to pull him back, but he was probably also feeling Izuku's pain, which made the whole matter way more difficult. Izuku tried to get on his feet and run after the train in order to lower his pain, but finding his footing was hard when he was literally being dragged by a speeding vehicle.

However, Katsuki's endurance was truly admirable. Before the train arrived at the next station, he found a way to pull Izuku back in. Since they had been standing at the back wagon when the train started moving, Katsuki simply crossed his way to the next wagon, and the next, ignoring the weird looks people were giving him (for walking as if he was dragging a phenomenal weight behind him – which he was, but they didn't know). The bond connecting them ended up pulling Izuku back into the train when Katsuki reached the second wagon, and he fell to the floor shakily, clearly in pain and in shock for everything that had happened in less than a minute.

He should have known this would happen. It only made sense – this was *physics* –, but he had been so distracted by Kacchan and their destination that he didn't realize it until it was too late. Katsuki, on the other hand, simply made his way back to the last wagon where Deku was fallen and crouched down beside him. He wished he could say he was thankful that there weren't that many people in that wagon to witness him talking to someone invisible, but the truth was he didn't care. He didn't even know those people. He didn't *care* if they thought he was batshit. All he could focus on in that moment was Deku, who was breathing heavily through his nose and had tears running down his cheeks.

Katsuki wished he could call him a crybaby, but he could feel the pain Deku was feeling. He wondered if he would have teased Deku, if he hadn't been feeling his pain, too.

Katsuki carefully lifted the back of Deku's ridiculous All Might shirt in order to take a look at his back, only to find it perfectly fine. So he could suffer from physical harm but it left no marks behind? What kind of weird fucking quirk had Deku been hit with?

Katsuki noticed a fresh, nearly bright scar crossing the entirety of Deku's back, but it didn't seem to be a result of being dragged by the train. His main instinct was to touch the pink flesh, but he was already drawing too much attention by crouching down over Deku like that in the middle of the train. Katsuki had a vague impression that the scar was a result from the villain's attack which had separated Deku from his body, but he decided he could investigate the matter further some other time, when there weren't dozens of eyes glued on him. He lowered Deku's shirt.

"Can you stand?", he asked, grabbing one of Izuku's elbows to offer him support. The train reached the station, coming to a halt, and Izuku would have slid out of it and into the tracks again if it hadn't been for Katsuki's hand holding him down. He yelped in discomfort as his back was dragged across the floor, and Katsuki bit his lower lip. "Come on, Deku. We're gonna end up making a scene. Just stand up. I'll help you", he offered again. Before Izuku could protest or even say anything at all, Katsuki placed the boy's arm behind his shoulder and hoisted him up, ignoring the pained sound Deku made at the movement.

Katsuki was also feeling the pain, which made it more difficult for him to support Izuku's weight, but he managed to place his own back against the wagon's wall and embraced Izuku, who instinctively buried his face on Katsuki's chest. He clung tightly to Katsuki for a moment, as if afraid to let him go, until he realized what he was doing and attempted to pull back in fear. Katsuki, despite of himself, held Izuku in place, not looking at him.

"This is the only way you won't phase through the train when it moves", Katsuki explained simply, his arms enveloping Deku and holding him close. He could see all the eyes in the wagon locked on him, but convinced himself that he didn't care. For those people, he was hugging air like a lunatic. For him, he was preventing himself from feeling the pain of having his back scraped on the floor as he was dragged by a train. For Deku – he didn't know what the hug meant to Deku.

If he was honest, he didn't know how to feel about the hug, either, so it was easier to convince himself that it was just to preserve his own well-being.

"Kacchan", Izuku said, voice muffled by Katsuki's chest. Katsuki repressed a shiver as the boy's hot breath contacted with his skin through the fabric of his shirt. "People must be staring".

"Tch", Katsuki shrugged with indifference. There was nothing else he could say.

Sure, he could break the hug, but that would mean risking Deku being yanked out of the train again as soon as it started moving. So he wasn't breaking the hug. He only had to endure it until they arrived at their station, which was just three stops ahead. He could take it. He would have to.

I'm only doing this for me, not for him, Katsuki told himself. *I don't give a shit about him*. *I'm just not in the mood to feel that kind of pain again, so I can't risk it. I can't let him go*.

He tried to erase the piercing sound of Deku's pained scream from his mind and failed.

“How’s the pain?”, he asked, voice barely above a whisper. Izuku couldn’t look at him – his face was still buried in Katsuki’s chest and his hands were clinging tightly to the back of his shirt. Katsuki already knew the answer to his question – he was feeling the pain himself, after all –, but asking Deku about it still felt like the right thing to do in that situation.

“It’s – It’s n-not that b-bad, now”, he stuttered. Katsuki knew he was lying, but said nothing. “I’ve been through worse”.

“Yeah, of *course* you fucking have. You break your bones every other damn day”, Katsuki scoffed tiredly. Feeling that sort of pain and dragging Deku back into the train had taken its toll on him, and his limbs were starting to feel heavy, as were his eyelids. All he wanted to do was lie down and take a nap, but he couldn’t do that until he accomplished his goal for the day.

Maybe doing this hadn’t been the best idea. Maybe they should go back while they still had access to the train station. Maybe he should just give the fuck up on this stupid attempt at making Deku happy, even if it was just a bit. What good had come out of it? Katsuki had ended up hurting him more than anything.

From the look of it, Katsuki *always* ended up hurting him more than anything.

“Kacchan”, Izuku called, face still buried in his chest. His voice sounded small, but it also sounded like he was trying his best to sound strong and brave.

“Hm”, Katsuki growled, indicating for the boy to continue.

“Thanks for pulling me back”, he said sincerely. Katsuki frowned. All thoughts of tiredness and desistance went forgotten by his mind.

“You think I’d just let you be dragged by the *fucking train* until we arrived?”, he asked, sounding almost offended. Izuku didn’t respond, which only made Katsuki even more furious. Did the shitty nerd really think that of him? Katsuki may have hated him, but he wouldn’t allow anyone to suffer like that. That was why he wanted to be a *hero*, for fuck’s sake. “Yeah. Ok”, Katsuki huffed, indignant by Deku’s lack of faith in him.

May have hated him.

Huh. He hadn’t realized that until then. When exactly had he stopped hating Deku?

“I – I’m sorry”, Izuku said, sounding honest. “Of course I didn’t think that. But still – thank you”.

“Whatever, shitty Deku”, Katsuki scoffed, not wanting to deal with that sort of bullshit.

“You know”, Izuku continued, even though Katsuki was definitely not in the mood for that conversation. He sighed to indicate his displeasure, but Izuku kept talking. “I don’t really get how this soul thing works. Why did the floor hurt me? Wasn’t it supposed to phase through me?”

“You’re literally standing on the floor right now, asshat”, Katsuki pointed out, annoyed. “You don’t phase through it. Or through my bed”.

“Yeah, I – I suppose”, Izuku swallowed dry and nodded. “But still. How did my back look?”

Katsuki tightened his lips into a straight line.

“It was normal. It only had one big ugly ass scar, but it didn’t look like it was from now”, he said sternly.

“Really? What did it look like?”, Izuku’s eyes widened against Katsuki’s chest, clearly unaware of his own scar.

“Ugly. And big”, Katsuki provided simplistically, repeating his words from before. Izuku sighed in frustration. “It looked like it was from the villain’s attack”, Katsuki added as an afterthought after a few moments.

An awkward silence fell between them, Katsuki continuing to hold him as the train moved and Izuku continuing to bury his face on Katsuki’s chest, even though he didn’t really have to. They were almost arriving at their stop.

“I’ll take a better look at it later, when we’re not surrounded by a bunch of nosy extras who think I’ve lost my damn mind”, Katsuki continued after a while. He could feel Deku relax in his hold at the words.

“S-Sir…?”, someone slowly approached Katsuki in that exact same moment – which was probably the universe’s way to mock the fuck out of him –, sounding hesitant and worried. Katsuki turned his head so that Izuku’s wild curls didn’t obstruct his view (he urgently needed a haircut), and found a woman in her mid-40s clutching her purse tightly and eyeing him with concern. She looked like she was afraid to approach him. “Are you… Are you okay?”, she asked, frowning, and nodding at him. Katsuki was once again made very aware that, to other people, he looked like he was hugging and talking to air. For some reason, the woman’s intrusion made him angry and annoyed.

“Yeah”, he said sharply, trying to indicate the conversation was over. The woman stayed where she was.

“We all saw you were talking to yourself, and…”, she continued, making Katsuki’s blood boil. “I – I know someone who can help you, if you need”.

“I don’t *need* your help”, he snapped, making the woman flinch and widen her eyes. He wasn’t anywhere as rude as he could have been, but given that this was a complete stranger in the middle of public transport, Katsuki decided that he was better off not telling the woman to go fuck herself (for now).

“I was just –“, she tried to say, but Katsuki cut her off.

“Don’t care. Bye”.

The woman blinked at him several times, looking conflicted and almost offended that Katsuki denied her so easily, before turning on her heels and going back to her seat. Katsuki noticed that she – along with several other passengers – kept sending him wary looks when they thought he wasn't looking. This was pissing him off really hard.

"How do you come up with so many swear words?", Izuku asked after a little while, breaking Katsuki away from his thoughts of anger and murder. He blinked several times, trying to understand what could have possibly caused Deku to reach that train of thought.

"The *fuck* are you talking about?", he frowned. "I didn't even swear at her".

Izuku gave him a tiny chuckle.

"Not her. You called me an asshat. Before that, you called me dipshit. And usually… you call me other things. That I'm not going to repeat", he concluded. Katsuki smirked, even though Izuku couldn't see it from where he was hiding his face away.

"Yeah, because saying 'dipshit' and 'asshat' is ok, but saying *fuck* isn't", he teased.

"*Kacchan*", Izuku groaned in disapproval.

"Just grow some fucking balls and say 'fuck' again", Katsuki provoked him.

"*No*!", Izuku immediately protested, sounding mortified.

"You had no problems saying it last night, nerd".

Izuku buried his face deeper into Katsuki's chest, cheeks burning with embarrassment.

"The situation was different and you know it. I was contaminated by your anger", he tried to justify, voice muffled.

"Heh?! *Contaminated?*", Katsuki growled, offended. He sounded like he was about to explode into an angry fit.

"That's not what I meant!", Izuku added desperately, sounding even more embarrassed. Katsuki suddenly broke their hug and Izuku's chest tightened – he hadn't meant to offend Kacchan, he was just speaking without thinking first! He really didn't want to throw all the progress they had made in the trash like that. But then he realized the train doors were open and Kacchan was already walking out, a hand tightening around Izuku's wrist and dragging him out as well. They managed to step out just as the train's doors were starting to close.

They stared at each other for a moment as the train departed and they stood on the station. Katsuki was staring into Izuku's green eyes with an unreadable look, and Izuku had no idea what he was thinking. Usually, Kacchan was an easy person to read – there was not much else into him other than anger and an unfaltering desire to be the best in everything he did. Now, there was something else in his crimson eyes – something that Izuku couldn't really understand. It didn't look like anger, though.

After what felt like an eternity, Kacchan let go of Izuku's wrist, so abruptly that it looked like he had been burned by the boy's skin. Before Izuku could even attempt to think of anything to say, Katsuki announced:

"That was enough touching for today".

And he turned on his heels and walked away.

Izuku followed.

"So…"

Silence.

"You're going to tell me where we're going?"

"One more fucking question about this and we're taking the train back to UA. And I won't hold you this time".

"You mean you won't *hug* me?"

"*Eh*?!"

"Oh, c'mon, Kacchan. Don't act like that wasn't a hug".

"I don't know what the fuck got into your brains, but that *wasn't* a hug. I was just keeping you from being fucking catapulted out of the train because your shitty soul can't cling to anything else".

"Why were your arms around me, then?"

"*What*?"

"You didn't have to embrace me like that. Just standing in front of me and serving as a shield was fine".

Awkward silence. Katsuki looked angry.

"You could barely stand on your fucking wobbly feet".

"I would have managed it".

“No, you wouldn’t. You were whimpering like a bitch”.

“Don’t say stuff like that!”

“But you were. You would have fallen on your ass if I hadn’t held you up. And I didn’t want to feel that kind of impact”.

“Uh. Right”.

They continued to walk side by side on the empty street, streaks of sunlight passing through the leaves and making Izuku’s hair shine in all different tones of green. Katsuki pointedly didn’t look at him, and did his best to ignore his thoughts about cutting the damn curls and taming them down. Deku’s hair was so fucking messy – how could it *not* bother him?

“Why do you find it so hard to show affection?”

Katsuki narrowed his eyes. He had *not* seen that coming.

“Are you fucking serious right now, shitty Deku?”

“I mean it. I don’t think I’ve ever seen you be affectionate towards someone before, and I’ve known you since we were four”.

“Shut the fuck up”.

“All you ever do is scream at people and be rude”.

“You see what the fucking problem is? I tell you to shut up because I don’t want to talk about this shit, and then what do you do? You go *right* the fuck ahead and keep talking anyway. And if I end up shutting your ass down and shove some truths on your face, you get all upset and teary-eyed like some weak-ass loser. Make up your fucking mind, because I’m getting done with this shit”.

Silence.

“Fuck, I knew I would end up regretting this. I don’t know why I even fucking bothered”.

“Sorry”, Izuku apologized, sounding sincere. “I’ll try to be… Less… Mumble-y”.

“Just shut the hell up altogether”.

Silence.

“But, if you ever want to talk about it –“

“*Deku*”.

“I’ll – I’ll be –“, he hesitated, sighing. “You can talk to me. If you want”.

“There’s *nothing* to talk about. Some people have the fucking patience to deal with this sort of bullshit, some people don’t. I’m the kind of the people who don’t”.

“It’s not bullshit, Kacchan”.

“I say it is”.

“But it isn’t!”

“Don’t think I won’t kick your ass just because I can feel what you feel. You’re really pissing me off right now”.

“Fine”.

More silence. From what Izuku could tell, they were headed to their neighborhood. Was Kacchan paying a visit to his parents?

Now that Izuku got to spend more time with Katsuki – more time than they had ever spent together throughout their lives, even though they knew each other from early childhood – he could finally attest something that had been really nagging him for a while. Kacchan was never affectionate. To *anyone*.

Izuku had low-key expected to find some affection between Kacchan and Kirishima-kun, since the two of them were so close, but there was nothing in their friendship other than playful, friendly banter. Izuku could tell that Kacchan liked Kirishima, even if he constantly called him names and referred to him as “Shitty Hair” most of the time. There was a sort of boyish friendliness between them – or *manly* friendliness, as Kirishima would call it –, but when Kacchan looked at Kirishima, there wasn’t fondness or affection in his eyes.

Izuku had never heard Kacchan say he loved someone, or express anything other than mild-annoyance towards a person at best. Even though that was just *Classic Kacchan*, the thought still bothered Izuku. Had he never loved someone? He wanted to know, but knew better than to ask.

Izuku tried to imagine himself referring to his mom as “old hag”, as Kacchan referred to *his* mom, and found that he couldn’t, not even hypothetically.

A weird noise called his attention and Izuku looked above his shoulder, spotting a quick shadow disappearing into a corner they’d just turned. Immediately alert, Izuku tightened his hands into fists, eyes becoming sharp.

“Kacchan”, he whispered, still looking behind his shoulder but never ceasing to walk. Katsuki didn’t pay him any mind. The shadow emerged from the corner and reappeared on the street, following them. From the distance, Izuku couldn’t make out a face or recognize the person. “*Kacchan*”, he whispered again, more urgently.

“*What*?”, Katsuki asked, sounding annoyed.

“I think we’re being followed”, Izuku said with another whisper, still looking above his shoulder. Katsuki frowned as if he thought Izuku was crazy and looked above his shoulder as well, following Izuku’s line of sight. Izuku could tell that, even though Kacchan didn’t look

like he had believed him, he had still tensed up and tightened his hands into fists as well, as if ready to engage in combat at any moment.

Then Katsuki relaxed, sighing in a mixture of relief and annoyance and turning back around.

“That’s just UA’s guard”, he said calmly – or as calmly as he managed to be, being *Kacchan*. Upon Izuku’s confused look, he rolled his eyes and added: “Aizawa sensei wouldn’t fucking let us come out without someone watching over our asses every fucking second. So he sent some people to escort us or whatever the fuck it is these clowns are doing”.

“Wait”, Izuku frowned. “They’ve been following us since we left?”

“Yeah”, Katsuki nodded. “I thought even your monkey brain would have realized it by now. No wonder *you’re* the one who ended up with the soul detached from the body”, he scoffed mockingly. Izuku sighed, but decided not to retort, lest he be accused by Kacchan of throwing things on his face again.

“I didn’t realize”, Izuku commented, at a lack of things to say.

“Clearly”, Katsuki clicked his tongue.

“Sorry if I was too busy getting *dragged by a train* to pay attention to the bodyguards following us, Kacchan”, Izuku sighed in annoyance. Katsuki scowled.

“Fuck, stop being so overdramatic”, Katsuki scowled. “Also, you’re catching my sarcasm and I don’t like it. *Stop*”.

“I wish I could”, Izuku groaned with sincerity. He really wasn’t having a good time picking up Kacchan’s mannerism. “I’m not a fan of feeling so angry all the time”.

“I’m also not a fan of feeling like my eyes are about to run a fucking cascade all the time, but which one of us is complaining about it, huh?”, Katsuki retorted grumpily, putting an end to the discussion. Izuku fell silent, sparing the person following them one last look above his shoulder before turning back, feeling at least relieved that they weren’t actually being followed by *villains*.

He should have realized Aizawa sensei wouldn’t be so reckless to the point of allowing two victims of a recent villain attack – one of which was still in a coma – to wander off around the city without protection. What he couldn’t realize for the life of him was why on *earth* Aizawa sensei would let them go out in the first place – what could possibly be so important that he would allow Katsuki to skip his afternoon classes, get out of UA grounds and be escorted around?

To Izuku’s surprise, the answer wasn’t as far away as he had thought. They didn’t turn on the corner that led to Katsuki’s apartment, which had been his first and primary guess. If they weren’t in the neighborhood to see Katsuki’s parents, then what was this about? Where were they *headed* to? Izuku’s instinct was to ask Katsuki about it, but he knew better than to play with his luck. He didn’t doubt Kacchan’s nerve to simply turn around and leave before they reached their destination just because Izuku was annoying him.

They walked into a familiar street, then into a familiar compound. It was only when they walked into a too-familiar building that Izuku's eyes narrowed in suspicion and realization, and he turned towards Kacchan with a questioning look in his eyes. A look that was almost hopeful.

Kacchan stared back at him, intense crimson eyes unreadable. They weren't looking as angry as they usually did.

Izuku said nothing and continued walking.

They only came to a stop when they arrived at a too-familiar door, and by that time, Izuku's eyes were already full of tears – tears of disbelief, of gratitude, of surprise. He couldn't believe Kacchan had gone through all this trouble for him. He couldn't believe *Kacchan*, of all people, had actually *done* this.

Katsuki kept his eyes fixed on Izuku as he raised his fist, knocked on the door, and waited.

Izuku wanted to sustain Kacchan's gaze, but failed as the door rattled and opened, revealing the confused, tired, worn-out figure of his mom.

Katsuki's eyes were still fixed on Izuku.

"Mom!", Izuku breathed out with pure joy, looking at his mother with wide, bright eyes. Inko, however, couldn't see him, focusing on Katsuki instead.

"K-Katsuki-kun?", she asked, frowning, worry evident in her eyes. To have a visit like that unannounced… She comprehensively thought something must have gone wrong with her son. "What is it? Is everything all right?"

"Yeah", Katsuki said simply, hands shoved in his pockets, not looking at her directly but no longer looking at Izuku, either. "I heard you weren't allowed to visit anymore, so I brought Deku over. Can we come in?", he asked, sounding way politer than Izuku was used to hearing him. If this had been any other moment, he would have felt impressed, but the sight of a polite Kacchan was subdued by the sight of his mother, who he had missed so much, standing in front of him.

"Oh", Inko exclaimed in surprise, her shoulders sagging in evident relief that nothing bad had happened to her son. "Oh, of course, dear. Come in, come in", she stepped aside so that Katsuki could enter the apartment. He walked in, stopping in the middle of the living room and looking around with nostalgia on his otherwise grumpy face. Izuku, on the other hand, couldn't take his eyes off his mom, desperately trying to touch her but failing to every time.

Katsuki could feel Izuku's frustration for not being able to interact with his mother deep in his chest, but he could also feel a deep sense of joy and utter happiness that he didn't recall ever feeling before in his entire life.

Katsuki didn't dare look at Izuku, lest the boy notice the sadness this realization etched into his crimson eyes.

Chapter End Notes

I'm not a big fan of how this one turned out, but hey. What can I say? I hope it's at least entertaining.
I've been wanting to write Katsuki's interaction with Inko for a while now, which is why I decided to take it off this chapter (which is long enough as it is) and give it its own chapter. Hope you guys enjoy this one and the next ones!
Trust me, there's a lot of fluff on the way. But since things have to be ballanced... There's angst coming, too.
Thank you all for supporting me and this story and leaving such nice comments! I love reading through each and every one of them, they really make me happy!
Thank you for reading and I'll see you on the next update!
(Also sorry if there are any typos or grammar mistakes in this it's literally 2 am rn)

Chapter 8: Bakugou is Totally Goddamn Fucking Okay With the Fact That His Katsudon Isn't Deku's Favorite (He's Not Pissed Off At All)

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Inko's hands were shaking a little as she placed a tray with hot tea in the small table in front of Katsuki.

He didn't look at her or at Deku. In fact, he didn't even look at the tea – he was too busy trying to avert his eyes from them as subtly as he could.

Katsuki couldn't say he was exactly comfortable at Deku's apartment. The last time he had been to that place, they had been four and he had just found out about his quirk. They hadn't known Deku was quirkless yet – and, once they found out, Katsuki never came over again.

He'd been there hundreds of times before that, though. Hundreds of times. He had memorized Deku's apartment, probably, and seeing it all again, after so many years, was unsettling.

Everything was still the same. It was very weird, seeing that the apartment had remained a constant whereas their relationship had changed so much.

(But whose fault was that?)

The thing about their relationship was – it had never been a friendship. Not from Katsuki's point of view, at least. Deku was just one of the many people who admired him for being amazing and who kissed his ass for being the best. He was nothing but a little, meaningless fanboy, like all the others. Surely, before they became old enough to have quirks, Deku had been Katsuki's favorite playmate from their neighborhood – even though he made fun of Deku and called him names in order to earn a laugh from the other kids, Deku had always been the one to come up with the best games. Sometimes, he'd climb on Katsuki's shoulders – since he'd always been stronger – and they would pretend to be Fourth Kind; sometimes, he'd try to carry Katsuki, fail, and agree to be the victim while Katsuki pretended to be All Might, ready to take him in his arms and carry Deku away to safety while he laughed loudly like the number one hero. Sometimes, Katsuki would pretend to be himself, rescuing Deku from mean imaginary villains with his imaginary quirk (since his own hadn't manifested yet).

He never allowed Deku to rescue him, though. Either they were heroes together, like when they pretended to be Fourth Kind or when Deku made up quirks of his own, or Deku was the victim. Never Katsuki.

Once Deku became quirkless, that all changed. Deku went from being Katsuki's favorite playmate, even if he was just another of many, to being nothing more than a pathetic little boy who wasn't even at the same rank as Katsuki.

And yet, Deku had stayed.

He was the only one who stayed.

Throughout Katsuki's life, he had many friends. All of them temporary, of course – nothing but extras desperate to share a bit of the spotlight that was constantly shining over Katsuki. For a long time, Katsuki thought Deku was one of those desperate losers seeking for what little scrap of momentary fame they could get – but that was until Deku got a spotlight of his own. A spotlight that outshined even Katsuki's.

The thought still enraged him. To know that Deku, who'd been nothing but a little pebble until a year ago, was shining as bright as him, who'd been the best for all his life…

"So, Katsuki-kun", Inko broke him away from his thoughts, sitting beside them on the couch from a polite enough distance. Katsuki looked up and met her eyes for the first time since he had arrived, trying his best not to let the anger from his introspection show so blatantly on his face. He didn't know why being over at Deku's made him so angry or brought back so many memories – all he knew was that he wanted to leave as soon as possible, despite all the trouble that it took to get them there.

Inko's eyes were green and big. Very expressive. Exactly like Deku's.

It bothered Katsuki, for some reason.

(He knew the reason; he just didn't want to think about it.)

(Dead, expressionless eyes, half-lidded, staring at him. Askew body. Lifeless body).

He suppressed a shiver.

"Yeah?", he replied, sounding bored. He'd never been the best at behaving near older people, even though he was usually the best at *everything* he did. Deku was sitting right beside him, so close that they were almost touching. Almost.

"H-How… How have you been?", Inko asked politely. Katsuki could tell that, even though her question sounded sincere, she was just using it to establish a conversation and reach the subject she truly wanted to discuss – her (shitty) son.

Katsuki sighed internally, doing his best not to be rude to Deku's mother. The boy might be a wimpy ass nerd loser, but if there was something Katsuki knew for sure, was that he really did love and respect his mother. He would probably get all whiny and angry if Katsuki offended her in any way, and that was the exact opposite of the result Katsuki was trying to accomplish with this visit.

The thought made him feel weird, but he didn't know why.

"It's just, the last I saw you, you had a pretty bad concussion, and since you didn't visit Izuku after that –", Inko continued after Katsuki didn't respond.

“I’m fine”, Katsuki cut her off (as politely as he could – which was not very polite for normal standards, but considerably so for *Katsuki* standards). Inko didn’t seem troubled by the interruption, and simply nodded.

“That’s good. I’m glad you’re fine. My Izuku would have wanted you to be”, she smiled sadly, misery and something akin to bitterness evident in her eyes. The similarity to Deku’s kicked-puppy expression was so uncanny that Katsuki found himself staring for longer than he should have. Before it got too weird, he bent over and grabbed his tea, holding the cup in his hand and waiting for the beverage to cool down a little.

“Kacchan”, Deku addressed him for the first time since they arrived at his home, as if he had just remembered Katsuki was there. Katsuki had found Deku’s silence so far very rude and frankly annoying, but opted not to say anything in order not to sound needy. Instead of giving Deku a passive-aggressive answer like he wanted to, he simply turned his head towards the boy, in silence. “M-Maybe you should… You know. Remind my mom that I’m here? And that I can hear her?”, he suggested hesitantly. Upon Katsuki’s frown of annoyed confusion, he added: “I d-don’t want her to say anything embarrassing”.

“Eh?”, Katsuki asked, intrigued. He could feel Inko’s eyes glued on him, paying attention to his interaction with her invisible son, but he didn’t have the mind to focus on her. “The hell is that supposed to mean?”, he scowled at Deku.

“Y-You know how moms are!”, Izuku tried to explain, sounding way too defensive for Katsuki’s liking. He wanted to say he *didn’t* know, but decided to stay quiet. “They like to tell baby stories and that sort of stuff. M-Maybe she’ll do something like that if she thinks I can’t hear her”.

“Huh”, Katsuki scoffed, turning back towards Inko, whose eyes were still fixed on him. He decided not to relay Deku’s message just yet, curious of what Inko may end up telling him.

“Is that Izuku? Is he talking to you?”, she asked, as if she thought Deku was some sort of entity that only spoke at determined times. Katsuki sighed and took a sip of his tea before responding. He had zero patience or tolerance to speak about this subject, especially to Deku’s mom, of all people, but he reminded himself that he was doing it for a greater good.

He was doing it so that he could feel better, and sleep better, and stop feeling so *miserable* all the time. Because he needed Deku to be happy so that he could be happy, right? That was the only reason why he was doing it. The *only* reason.

Also, he had come all the way to Deku’s shitty home. Katsuki could be many things, but when he put his mind into doing something, he *never* half-assed it. If he was going to make Deku happy, he was going to make him happy *as fuck*. And if to accomplish that he would need to waste time chatting with his wimpy mom, then he would do it like a fucking pro, no matter how annoying that was.

That didn’t mean he had to go all happy-go-lucky on her. Nah. Some things, he simply couldn’t change about himself.

“He’s always talking to me”, Katsuki explained, placing his tea back on the table and leaning back on the couch in a very impolite manner – his arms half-stretched as he leaned his elbows on the backrest and one of his legs crossed in a spread-out way. “I can see him as if he was in his body. He’s not transparent or anything”, he shrugged. He could tell Deku was nervous beside him, but didn’t bother looking at him. Inko’s eyes widened and she nodded her head in understanding.

“Oh”, she said, surprised, taking one hand to her chin. “I didn’t know that. I thought – I’d pictured him… Floating, like a ghost, you know?”

“Nah”, Katsuki shrugged again, looking away from her big green eyes and bearing his usually grumpy expression. “Nothing like that. It looks just like Deku, except he can’t touch anything other than me”.

“He – can *touch* you?!”, Inko exclaimed, eyes widening even further. Katsuki wished she’d stop doing that with her fucking stupid green eyes, but didn’t comment on it. Instead, he gave her a questioning look.

Why did no one tell her about any of this? Katsuki couldn’t have told her himself, since he hadn’t visited Deku at the medical bay ever since the day he woke up, but All Might and all the special board of the UA knew about that information. Why hadn’t it been shared with Deku’s next of kin?

Katsuki’s original plan had been to go to Recovery Girl’s medical bay so that Deku could see his mom and quit whining about missing her, but one quick text conversation with Kirishima let him know that Mrs. Midoriya was no longer allowed into the UA infirmary.

Text conversations were probably the last scrap of privacy Katsuki had left, since Deku was glued to him 24/7 now and could listen to almost everything he said and heard. So, taking advantage of the sigil from Deku’s nosy nature that his phone’s texts provided him, Katsuki asked Kirishima why Inko had been banned from visiting, but not even the boy knew. All he could tell was that the Half’n’Half bastard – who, apparently, was the person who visited Deku’s shitty body the most, for some reason, only after All Might – had told them that Inko hadn’t been around at the infirmary for a while, and that when he asked Recovery Girl about it, she said the woman was no longer allowed to visit. Being the useless loser he was, Icy Hot didn’t even consider asking the old woman about the reason behind the ban, leaving all of them in the dark.

Katsuki wanted to know, but he knew it would probably be impolite to ask Inko about it directly. He didn’t really give a damn about being polite, usually, but he knew how to be subtle around figures of authority – or, at least, *more* subtle than he usually was.

“Yeah. I’m the only person he can touch”, he provided simply, not looking at Deku or at his mom. He was feeling extremely uncomfortable, but he forced himself to meet her eyes as he continued: “Didn’t they tell you about that?”

Inko nervously sustained his gaze and Katsuki forced himself not to look away. He hoped she would be able to spot the hidden question in his eyes.

She lowered her head and played with the hem of her skirt as she avoided Katsuki's eyes, looking grievous. She didn't look ashamed or guilty, which Katsuki supposed was a good sign – that probably meant the ban hadn't been her direct fault.

"I – I haven't been receiving much information about Izuku's condition recently. You and the other kids probably know more about him than I do right now", she shrugged miserably. Deku perked up on the sofa beside Katsuki, looking indignant.

"What? Why not, mom?", he protested, even though his mother couldn't hear him. Katsuki rolled his eyes at the stupid emotional outburst, but did his best not to slap Inko's ghost-son in front of her as she continued.

"I – I didn't do anything, if that's what you're wondering about. It's just –", she hesitated. "The principal and the board of teachers decided it would be better if no outsiders were allowed into the UA grounds, to preserve Izuku's privacy and prevent a possible villain invasion. I – I couldn't sleep there, because of my job, so I had to keep going in and out –"

"But you're my mom! They shouldn't keep you from seeing me!", Deku protested again.

" – and they claimed that this flux wasn't safe for the school security, which… Makes sense, of course. This is why I got so worried when I saw you at my door", she offered Katsuki a small shy smile, that somehow looked resentful. "If they didn't allow anyone in, I assumed they wouldn't allow anyone out as well, especially since… Well", she trailed off with a small sigh.

She looked worn out. There were heavy bags under her eyes and her hair looked more disheveled than Katsuki remembered it. She used to be taller, too, now that he thought about it. Taller and prettier. He vaguely recalled referring to her as 'Aunty Inko' when he was a kid, but the memory felt like it was from a different lifetime. A different person.

"We didn't come alone", Katsuki explained. Somehow, he felt like that information needed to be shared with her. "Our sensei sent an escort of UA guards to keep an eye for us on the way here".

Inko eyed him with a weird look in her eyes, even though there was a fraction of gratitude in them. She stared at Katsuki for a few moments, taking a sip of her own tea before speaking her mind.

"I… don't understand, Katsuki-kun", she admitted. *Get in the fucking line*, Katsuki wanted to reply, but held his tongue. "Why go through all the trouble of coming over if nothing's wrong with Izuku? Don't get me wrong –", she added quickly. "I am really thankful for the visit, but… I –", she swallowed dry, hesitant. "If I'm being honest, I didn't expect this from you".

Yeah, there went all his attempts at keeping his cool.

"*Eh*? The *hell* is that supposed to mean?", he protested before he knew better, a direct result of his short-fused temper. Inko didn't falter upon his abrupt reaction, but rather tilted her chin up in defiance, the hand holding her tea cup tightening its grip until her knuckles were white.

She looked like she was trying her best not to lose composure, but there was a clear grudge in her eyes that she had been hiding for the sake of politeness until now.

“There’s no need to pretend, Katsuki-kun”, she said, setting her cup down on the table and intertwining her fingers on her lap. She looked like she wanted to cry, even though she was… angry? Upset? Irritated? Katsuki couldn’t tell for the life of him what that tiny woman was thinking. “I know you don’t like my Izuku, even though he’s done nothing but admire you his whole life”, she accused.

For some reason, the words felt like a punch to his stomach, and Katsuki couldn’t tell if the feeling had been his own or just a mirror of Deku’s, who was looking very pale and very nervous beside him.

“I’ve lost count of how many times I had to call Mitsuki because my boy came back home all battered and bruised”, Inko shook her head in disapproval. “He never told me who hurt him, but I *knew* it was you. The simple fact that you call him that horrible nickname, *Deku,* inside my own home – is a strong point that supports my confusion. So let me ask you – why are you truly here?”

Katsuki stared at Deku’s mom. She looked nervous – not afraid, but shaky about confronting Katsuki like that. She also looked like she had meant to talk about this subject for a long time now, but never had the chance to. Most of all, she looked strong. Strong as *fuck*. Way stronger than Katsuki would have expected a tiny, chubby woman with no relevant quirk and teary, baggy eyes like herself to be.

Her lower lip was wobbling and her eyes were full of unshed tears – *uncanny. fucking. resemblance.* –, but there was a familiar determination on her face that told Katsuki there was no way out of this but answering with sincerity. But just how fucking weird – and horribly egoistic, if he was being honest – would it be if he straight up told Inko Midoriya that the reason he was there was because he could feel it when her son was in pain, and Deku had been feeling miserable lately because he missed her, so Katsuki decided to beg Aizawa sensei for a special license to go visit her so that the shitty nerd would finally quiet down and stop making Katsuki’s chest feel so fucking tight all the time?

He couldn’t just *say* that. He knew how bad it would sound. But what other choice did he have?

Katsuki sucked at lying. He didn’t like it. And, most of all, he wasn’t about to throw all his principles out of the window just so that he could please shitty Deku’s mom with an answer that would make him sound less like a piece of shit.

Everyone already thought he was a piece of shit. Inko Midoriya certainly thought so, too. Why bother pretending he wasn’t one?

“I found something out. About the quirk that’s connecting me and Deku”, he started, not meeting her eyes. Instead, he simply stared to the side, his trademark grumpy look still coloring his face and his eyes narrowing in annoyance.

“The soulbonding quirk”, Inko nodded in acknowledgment. “All Might told me this much”.

“Yeah. The quirk connects us in a way that we can’t get away from each other”, he continued, still avoiding her eyes. “And we can also feel what the other is feeling”.

Inko was silent. Katsuki wanted to look at her to see what her reaction was, but found that he couldn’t. For some reason, he couldn’t look that woman in the eye anymore.

That was ridiculous. What was she going to do to him? Katsuki forced himself to stop being such a pussy and glared at her with anger, even though she had done nothing to earn it.

“So Deku’s been feeling pretty miserable lately, because he misses you and all that shit. So I decided to pay you a visit”, he continued with a shrug, hoping Inko would not read in between the lines of what he was saying. Unfortunately, he had no such luck.

“So you’re only doing this”, she said, voice heavy with disapproval, “because you can feel what my son is feeling. And, since he was feeling miserable because he missed me… You didn’t want to feel miserable too?”

Katsuki lowered his head, looking angry. He didn’t respond, or even nod his head.

Inko was silent for a long time. Katsuki could tell Deku’s eyes were darting nervously between him and his mom, but he didn’t bother looking at the nerd. He didn’t want to see what expression he would find in those godforsaken green eyes.

“Well…”, Inko said after a long while, sighing and standing up from her seat. Katsuki looked at her, surprised to find not anger on her face, but calmness and a bit of sadness. “Thank you for being honest with me, Katsuki-kun”.

She took his cup and placed it along with hers on the tray before taking it and heading into the kitchen without saying anything else. Katsuki could still see her, since it was an open kitchen, but her back was turned to him and the distance between them was so great that she may as well have been in other room.

Katsuki hadn’t been expecting that sort of response. He slowly tilted his head so that he could read Deku’s face and find out if that had been a normal reaction for his mom, but he looked as confused as Katsuki felt. The water from the sink started to run and Inko didn’t give any signs that she was about to leave the kitchen any time soon.

Maybe she just needed some time to think. Her son had been turned into a ghost and glued to the guy who spent years bullying him. Now said guy was in her house years after last visiting, telling her about sharing feelings with her ghost son and being able to touch him when no one else could. That was a whole fucking lot to process. It was only natural that she would need some time to herself.

Katsuki realized with surprise and shock that, if this had happened a month before, he would have burst into the kitchen in anger, screaming about not wanting to be ignored.

He didn’t want to think about what that change in behavior meant.

He stood up from the couch, feeling too restless to just sit still and wanting to occupy his mind with something other than this kind of thoughts. Surely, he was feeling tired as fuck after the whole train shitshow, but something about his conversation with Inko had bothered him and he didn't want to end up falling asleep on the couch or getting too lost in deep thought. He'd better get moving.

Deku stayed on the couch as Katsuki paced across the living room, checking photo frames, furniture and decoration items without putting any mind into it. His head was rushing with thousands of thoughts per hour – an influence from Deku's shitty mumbling habits, he was sure – and he couldn't really focus on anything.

Maybe Inko thought it was unfair that her son had ended up glued to a person that hated him, instead of someone who loved him, like her or All Might. And it really *was* unfair. Didn't she understand that Katsuki didn't want this? That he wasn't having a great time with this situation, either? That the last thing he wanted to be doing was to stand in the middle of this woman's fucking living room while she did the dishes, feeling inadequate and like an intruder in a house that once had been like a second home to him?

Katsuki ended up finding his way to a half-open photobook sitting on the dinner table behind the couch. Inko had probably been taking a look at it before Katsuki arrived.

He looked at her. She didn't look at him, too busy chopping vegetables and looking like she was getting started in the process of cooking something.

Katsuki grabbed the photobook and threw himself on the couch impolitely, startling Deku. As soon as Izuku saw what Katsuki was holding, his eyes widened, and he tried to jump off the couch to prevent Katsuki from looking through the photobook. Katsuki, on the other hand, skillfully placed both his legs on the top of Izuku's lap as he half-lay, half-sat on the couch, weighting the limbs down and preventing the boy from standing up. Deku struggled against the weight of Katsuki's legs, which earned an evil smirk from explosive boy.

"Wait, Kacchan!", Deku protested as Katsuki opened the book and started to go through the photos glued on the first page. "You shouldn't look at that without permission! It's not polite!", he pointed out, ending up sounding a lot like Iida, if Iida was a desperate, nervous nerd who was blushing really hard in fear of Katsuki seeing his baby pictures while he struggled to get free from beneath Katsuki's legs.

"Since when do I give a shit about being *polite*, nerd?", Katsuki scoffed, continuing to go through the album. Deku tried to remove it from Katsuki's hands and failed, his own hands phasing through the material of the album as he fruitlessly tried to pull it from Katsuki's grasp.

The first pages consisted of nothing other than pictures of Deku as a baby, bald and ugly as fuck but already bearing those ridiculous freckles on his face. As the pages went by, Deku's growth became evident – green curls emerging from the top of his head, little baby teeth growing in his mouth and those stupid, big green eyes staring straight into Katsuki's soul. He looked up from the picture to find Deku staring at him nervously and biting at one of his nails. He was watching Katsuki like a hawk. With those same eyes.

“S-See? There’s nothing there but baby pictures, Kacchan”, Deku said nervously, not understanding why Katsuki was staring at him with such intensity but clearly trying to talk him into dropping the album and putting it back into place. “You don’t – You don’t even like babies! Why don’t you just put that away?”

“Shut the fuck up, Deku”, Katsuki scoffed, averting his gaze back to the album on his lap. “I want to see what you’re so scared about me finding out, so shut it and be a good leg rest”.

“I’m – I’m – I’m not *scared*! T-There’s nothing for you to f-find out!”, Izuku stuttered. “I j-just don’t think you should waste your time on something like this… And how are your legs so *heavy*?”, he complained, still trying to lift Katsuki’s legs from his lap.

“I’ve been working out since I was a brat, unlike you”, he huffed with indifference. There was a hint of bitterness in his tone as well. “Also, what the fuck else am I supposed to spend my time on? Your shitty mom is doing whatever the hell she’s doing in the kitchen, and I didn’t come all the way here just to leave after five minutes of crap talk. I’m hungry as fuck, so Imma eat whatever the hell it is she’s making, then we can go. Until then, I’m going to stare at your ugly baby face”, he scoffed with indifference.

“Don’t call my mom shitty”, Izuku protested in a serious, offended voice, making Katsuki roll his eyes really hard.

“Whatever”, he sighed, turning several pages with boredom. Baby Deku, baby Deku, baby Deku – was that *all* this album consisted of? What was so interesting about baby Deku that made him mom take a hundred fucking pictures of him? Some of them were even from the exact same angle, snapped on the exact same moment! Katsuki couldn’t understand it.

His mom barely ever took photos of him – all the ones he had were enough to fill up one single album, from age 0 to 15. Deku, on the other hand, probably had an album for each year of his shitty, uninteresting life.

As Katsuki reached half of the album, Deku (finally) started to grow up. Now he had teeth, hair, and that stupid ass grin on his face. There were pictures of him in the park where he and Katsuki used to play as kids, pictures of him at the beach, pictures of him in his bedroom. There was a picture of him, wearing his All Might hoodie and standing beside a tall All Might figurine at a shopping mall; a picture of him, wearing the same hoodie, hugging an All Might doll to his chest on the beach; a picture of him, wearing a similar All Might hoodie – but not the same one – and posing in All Might’s traditional heroic pose.

“Finally reached the All Might phase”, Katsuki told Deku with a scoff and a smirk on his lips. Deku, on the other hand, blushed and hid his red face beneath the crook of both his arms, looking embarrassed and shrinking away as far as possible from Katsuki with his legs pinning him into place.

Beside each photo, there was an annotation – probably from Deku’s mom – explaining the context of the picture, the place where it had been taken, and Deku’s age. Katsuki alternated between chuckling, scoffing, rolling his eyes, and smirking as he read the descriptions:

Izuku – age 1. Having fun at the beach with mom!

Izuku – age 1. Just said his first word! I think it was “mom”!

Izuku – age 1. Went to the mall for the first time!

Izuku – age 1. Went to the park for the first time! He didn’t like the sand, even though he didn’t seem to mind it at the beach!

Izuku – age 1. Won his first All Might figurine! He wanted an Endeavor one, but there weren’t any at the shop! Now he never lets go of it!

Izuku – age 1. Playing in the park with All Might doll!

Izuku – age 1 and a half. Won his first All Might hoodie! He never takes it off anymore!

Izuku – age 1 and a half. Playing in the park with All Might hoodie and doll! He likes the sand now!

Izuku – age 1 and a half. Taking a bath with All Might shampoo!

Izuku – age 1 and a half. Taking a nap at the couch after watching an All Might video!

Izuku – age 1 and a half. Mom gave him another All Might hoodie so that she could wash the first one!

Izuku – age 1 and a half. Mom gave him another All Might hoodie so that she could wash the first and the second one!

Izuku – age 2. Izuku’s second birthday!

Izuku – age 2. Izuku with his collection of hero figurines! His favorite is All Might! He doesn’t care about Endeavor anymore!

Izuku – age 2. Fourth All Might hoodie Izuku won for his second birthday! Little boys grow so fast!

Izuku – age 2. Izuku and his drawing of All Might!

Izuku – age 2. Izuku posing as a hero!

Izuku – age 2. Izuku watching All Might save people on TV! He doesn’t understand, but he does the All Might dance!

Izuku – age 2 and a half. Playing hero with mom! Izuku to the rescue!

Izuku – age 2 and a half. Izuku singing the All Might theme song in the bath!

Izuku – age 2 and a half. Fifth All Might hoodie!

Izuku – age 2 and a half. Izuku and his collection of All Might dolls!

Izuku – age 3. Izuku’s third birthday! He had an All Might themed party!

Izuku – age 3. Izuku and his drawing of his hero agency for when he grows up! He wants it to be called “All Might’s Agency”, even if mom told him that he should pick his own name!

Izuku – age 3. Izuku playing in the park with some friends!

Izuku – age 3. Izuku and a tiny turtle he found in the sand! Cute!

Izuku – age 3. Izuku at the beach with mom! He loves it, even if there’s more trash than there used to be!

Izuku – age 3. Izuku on a train ride with mom!

Izuku – age 3 and a half. Playing hero with mom again! He can’t decide what his hero name will be!

Izuku – age 3 and a half. All Might Jr. and his increasing All Might doll collection!

Izuku – age 3 and a half. Small Might helping mom cook dinner!

Izuku – age 3 and a half. Mighty Boy drawing in his bedroom after a nap!

Izuku – age 3 and a half. Mighty All Man taking a bath on his own! (Mom kept an eye out all the time to prevent accidents!)

Izuku – age 3 and a half. Izuku fell asleep while playing!

Izuku – age 4. Izuku’s fourth birthday! All Might themed again! He didn’t want to eat the cake not to cut All Might’s face!

Izuku – age 4. Made some new friends at the park!

Izuku – age 4. Sixth All Might hoodie! It’s his favorite so far!

Izuku – age 4. Learning how to use the computer! He doesn’t know how to type yet!

Izuku – age 4. Izuku’s new heroic pose!

Izuku – age 4. Izuku doing groceries with mom!

Izuku – age 4. Izuku and his best friend Kacchan!

Katsuki’s eyes were glued to the photo and the caption, his fingers gripping at the album with more strength than necessary. It was a picture of him and Deku at the park where they had met, hugging each other and smiling widely at the camera. It was just the two of them. Izuku looked happy. Katsuki looked happy. They were both wearing identical All Might hoodies, which made them look fucking ridiculous. Katsuki turned to look at Deku, but found that the boy was still hiding his face away in embarrassment, not even aware of what photo Katsuki was looking at.

He averted his eyes from the picture uncomfortably and turned the page.

Izuku – age 4. Playing with Kacchan in the park!

Izuku – age 4. Learning how to read! He is really dedicated!

Izuku – age 4. Izuku and his drawing of himself, Kacchan, and All Might!

Izuku – age 4 and a half. Izuku playing with his new All Might themed ball!

Izuku – age 4 and a half. Izuku learning how to type on the computer!

Izuku – age 4 and a half. Izuku and Kacchan doing the All Might dance choreography!

(Katsuki blushed at that one and quickly turned the page).

Izuku – age 4 and a half. Izuku eating katsudon for the first time! He wanted to eat it because it had "katsu" in the name, like his friend!

What the goddamn *hell* was that supposed to mean?! Katsuki skipped several pages just because of that.

Izuku – age 4 and a half. Seventh All Might hoodie!

Izuku – age 5. Izuku's fifth birthday! Kacchan came over and helped Izuku cut the All Might cake without worrying about the face! That's what friends are for!

Izuku – age 5. Izuku at the beach with Kacchan and his parents!

Izuku – age 5. Kacchan came over to show Izuku his quirk! Explosive!

Izuku – age 5 and a half. Izuku playing in the park!

Izuku – age 5 and a half. Izuku making his new super hero pose!

Izuku – age 5 and a half. Izuku helping mom make All Might themed biscuits!

Izuku – age 5 and a half. Eighth All Might hoodie!

Izuku – age 5 and a half. Izuku playing with his new All Might figurine!

Izuku – age 5 and a half. Izuku's first notebook! He knows how to write now!

Izuku – age 6. Izuku's sixth birthday! Mom helped him cut the cake this time, since Katsuki-kun couldn't come over!

Izuku – age 6. Izuku taking notes on his notebook! Such a clever boy!

Izuku – age 6. Ninth All Might hoodie!

Izuku – age 6. Trying to guess what his quirk will be with mom!

Izuku – age 6. Izuku playing doctor before his appointment tomorrow! What will his quirk be?! Looking forward to it!

Izuku – age 10. Izuku and mom at the beach

Katsuki frowned at the huge time lapse. For someone who'd been registering her son's development so closely, Katsuki found it weird that Inko had stopped it so suddenly and for four years. He was almost at the end of the photo book now.

Then he realized it. That was the last photo she had taken of Deku before they found out he didn't have a quirk.

Katsuki stared at that wide, sincere smile on 6-year-old Deku's face. Fuck. He had no clue how much his life was about to change, right?

How fucking sappy. Katsuki kept looking through the album.

Izuku – age 12. Mom's birthday with Izuku

Izuku – age 13. Izuku's birthday

Izuku – age 14. Izuku's birthday

Izuku – age 15. Izuku's birthday

Katsuki's frown deepened. Deku looked like a completely different person in these photos – no longer the cheery, lively, grinning little boy he had been as a kid, but a gloomy, bony, miserable shadow of himself. The smile he was giving the camera looked sincere, but also… Weird. It lacked Deku's usual cheeriness that pissed Katsuki off more often than not. He looked… miserable.

Katsuki kept going through what was left of the album.

Izuku – age 15. His quirk manifested!!! Really happy!!!

(It was a picture of Deku making his All Might pose, looking so terribly different from the previous photos – not only because he was happier, but because he looked *buffer* – that Katsuki found his eyes widening in surprise. He didn't think he had ever noticed the difference, since he saw Izuku every single day at school. Now that he saw the pictures together – from age 14 and age 15 –, he could see how much muscular mass Deku had gained in half a year.)

Izuku – age 15. IZUKU GOT ACCEPTED INTO UA!!! REALLY HAPPY!!!

(Deku holding his letter of acceptance and smiling so widely that his freckles almost disappeared.)

Izuku – age 15. Izuku's first day at UA!

Izuku – age 15. Izuku wearing his hero costume!! Mom loves that he loved it!

Izuku – age 15. Izuku at the Sports Festival! He was amongst the 8 best!

(It was just a picture of the TV).

Izuku – age 15. Izuku and All Might! A dream come true!

Izuku – age 16. Izuku's 16th birthday! Friends Uraraka, Tenya, and Shouto came over!

Katsuki scoffed, feeling something ugly blossoming in his chest. He didn't know why the picture bothered him so much, but decided it would be better not to dwell on it. He moved on.

Izuku – age 16. Izuku and All Might at his 16th birthday! He came over as a surprise!

Izuku – age 16. Izuku and his new uniform!

Izuku – age 16. Izuku and his best friends Uraraka and Tenya!

Katsuki scoffed again. The photo album had come to an end, so he closed it unceremoniously, tossing it at the coffee table. He finally turned his head to look at Deku, who was still hiding his face, looking very embarrassed. His face was so red his freckles disappeared, but he had uncovered his eyes in order to look at Katsuki, apprehension evident in them. He had stopped struggling against Katsuki's legs.

"I don't know what the fuck you were so embarrassed about, nerd", Katsuki commented, feeling grumpier than when he arrived. "There was nothing compromising there. Just some dumbass baby pictures and kid's stuff. The fuck does your mom take so many photos for, anyway?", he scoffed.

Izuku uncovered his face and sat up straighter on the couch beside Katsuki, his face still red. He didn't look at Katsuki as he responded, staring at his own knees instead while his fingers played with the hem of his shirt absentmindedly.

"Ah, s-she… She used to take a lot of pictures to send to my dad. But she kept copies and decided to make a photobook with them", he shrugged. Katsuki blinked blankly at him.

Now that he thought about it, Deku's father wasn't in a single picture he'd seen. In fact, Katsuki couldn't remember ever meeting Deku's father in the first place. He wanted to ask Deku about it, but sparing one single look at him and feeling what the boy was feeling, Katsuki immediately knew this wouldn't be a good idea. This was a subject that they shouldn't talk about, unless Deku talked about it first.

Whatever, who gives a shit about the shitty nerd's dad anyway, Katsuki told himself mentally as he threw his legs off Deku's lap and stood up from the couch abruptly, deciding to ignore the fact that he, indeed, gave a shit, only if it was out of curiosity.

"Anyway, I don't know why the fuck you were making such a fuss about", Katsuki said, closing the photobook and walking around the couch in order to place it back at the dinner table. "There weren't even that many naked baby photos –"

He was cut off as something fell from inside the album and to the floor. Deku's eyes widened so hard at this that they looked about to pop out of his skull, and before he could protest – or better, dive into the floor and keep Katsuki from taking whatever it was that had fallen from the album – Katsuki bent over and picked it up himself. It was an envelope which appeared to contain several sheets of paper inside.

"Oi, oi, what is this?", Katsuki chuckled and offered the terrified Izuku an evil smirk. The boy stared back at him, his face redder than before – if that was even possible –, and Katsuki waved the package at him playfully, teasing. "Is this what you didn't want me to see?", he grinned wickedly.

"Just put it back, Kacchan!", Deku called out, looking serious. The way he was blushing violently obliterated any possible trace of seriousness he may have mustered into his voice.

"Or what? You'll tell your *mom*?", Katsuki provoked, raising his eyebrows at Deku and giving him a smug look. He felt like the 4-year-old who bullied Deku all over again, but he didn't mind. Inko didn't even hear the taunting from where she was concentrating on cooking. "Whatever this is, it can't be worse than seeing your ugly baby butt in the shower", Katsuki placed the photo album back where he had taken it from and made his way back to the couch with the envelope. He threw himself instead of properly sitting down, but didn't pin Deku with his legs this time.

"I didn't ask you to see those photos! You're the one who wanted to!", Deku protested, looking frantic but sitting very still beside Katsuki. "Wait!", he grabbed Katsuki's wrist right as he opened the envelope, ready to remove its contents. Katsuki stared up at him with a no-shit expression. "I just – I don't want you to see it. Ok, Kacchan?", Deku told him with a serious frown. Katsuki wanted to mock him or tell him something in the lines of *I don't give a fuck what you want*, but given the fact that he could *feel* Deku's anxiety, he decided to give him a chance to explain.

"Why?", he scoffed with narrowed eyes.

"Because it's *embarrassing*!", Deku whined as if it was obvious, voice high pitched. Katsuki rolled his eyes and yanked his hand out of Deku's grip before removing the contents from the envelope without further ado. Not a good enough excuse, that one.

"I've known you since we were four, Deku. I'm pretty sure I've already witnessed your peak embarrassing moments", he said as he took a look at the papers from inside the envelope.

First, there was a series of drawings from Deku. They looked like a compilation – some were very childish and bore barely discernible shapes, while others were more elaborated and colorful and had clearly been made by an older Deku – probably from when he was around 5 or 6 years old. The first drawings, from when he was younger, all depicted the same subject – All Might. Whether it was just a blue block with two yellow strings on the top or a more recognizable drawing of the number one hero, it was evident that he was the main subject of most of Deku's drawings.

There were some drawings of Deku and his mom, Deku and All Might, and Deku and Katsuki, but they were all childish and badly-done. Katsuki wanted to mock Deku for his

clear lack of art skills as a kid, but Katsuki's own drawings used to be pretty bad at that time, too (not that he would ever admit it).

However, to his surprise, All Might stopped being the subject of Deku's drawings all of a sudden. From the dates Inko had written at the corners of the drawings, Katsuki figured Deku must have been around 6 years old at that time. Was that the same time he found out he was quirkless? Was that the same time Deku stopped taking pictures?

Instead of All Might, he had started to draw Katsuki.

It was way too fucking weird to see how accurately Deku had predicted how Katsuki's hero costume would turn out to be – he had gotten almost everything right, except for the grenades and the headwear. Even so, there were drawings over drawings of *Kacchan*, many of them which included Izuku either watching him from the distance or praising him, but never standing close to him. In fact, now that Katsuki bothered to pay attention to it, there were more drawings of himself than of *All Might*.

He turned to look at Deku again. Katsuki had no idea what his own face looked like on that moment – was it angry? Surprised? Horrified? Figuring his feelings out was already a hard task to him, but it became even harder after Deku started shoving his own confusing emotions into the mix –, but Deku cringed as soon as his head snapped to the side, probably afraid of his reaction.

Katsuki was about to ask Deku what the fuck that was all about when Inko finally returned from the kitchen, after what felt like an eternity but could have only been minutes. She was wearing an apron and her forehead was sweaty, but she sat down on the couch and sighed heavily.

"Well, now we just have to wait for it to cook", she announced, running the back of her hand across her forehead and only then noticing the several sheets of paper on Katsuki's lap. She looked surprised for a moment, before eyeing Katsuki with curiosity.

"Oh", she said simply. "You took the photo album?"

"Yeah", he admitted, not knowing whether he should feel embarrassed or not about being caught red-handed. He didn't *feel* embarrassed, but *should* he?

"Ah, that's ok", Inko waved a hand at him, looking tired. "I just like seeing his pictures, you know? It helps me when I miss him", she sighed. Katsuki clenched the hand that was grasping the drawings, not knowing how to proceed and not caring that he was probably crinkling them.

Katsuki wanted to ask Inko about them, since she was more likely to give him a satisfying response than Deku, but he also didn't *want* to know. Something told him he *wouldn't* want to know why Deku drew him so much as a kid.

"He was such a cheerful kid", she commented with nostalgia, a sad look contrasting with the smile on her lips and clearly oblivious to Katsuki's internal conflict. She reached over and took the drawing Katsuki was holding from his hands – it was a drawing of him, shouting and

making an explosion with his hands while he fought a poorly drawn villain and Deku cheered on the background. Inko stared at the drawing with emotion in her eyes. “He used to love playing heroes and making up hero names for himself. After he got diagnosed…”, she trailed off, sadness overtaking her features. She set the drawing down on the coffee table with a sigh. “There wasn’t anything he could have done other than reach out for the closest thing he had to a hero. I think he wanted you to be the hero he thought he would never get to be, you know?”, she looked up at Katsuki.

He didn’t know what to say. He didn’t know how to react. The mother of the guy he had spent most of his life bullying and putting down was telling him that said guy saw him as a hero. As *his* hero.

When, exactly, had Katsuki been a hero to Deku? When he pushed him down and laughed at him for being weak? When he beat him and mocked him for being defenseless? When he bullied him and told him he was a good for nothing, a waste of space, a pathetic loser?

When he told him to jump off a building?

Why the fuck did fucking Deku admire him so much, when Katsuki never gave him any reasons to? What the *fuck* was wrong with him?

He snapped his head to look at Deku, this question evident in his crimson eyes. Deku, however, refused to meet his gaze, refused to look at him, refused to do anything other than hide his face away in embarrassment. Fucking coward.

“But now my Izuku has a quirk, and he is going to be the hero he’s always dreamed of being”, Inko continued upon Katsuki’s silence, unaware of the weight her words were taking on him. “And – And I’m sure he is going to be the *best*”.

Katsuki’s hands clenched into fists.

Izuku finally looked at him, his face still red but his eyes wide with a silent warning, a silent plea at his mother’s words. *Please don’t fight her. Not on this. Not this time. She’s having a hard enough time as it is.*

Tch.

“Deku –“, Katsuki started, but upon a disapproving look from Inko at the use of the nickname, he cleared his throat in annoyance. God, the little asshole had already taken *that* as his superhero name. Why did it still bother his shitty mom so much? She should just get with the program. “*He* – wants you to know that he thinks it sucks they aren’t letting you see him anymore”, he said. Did Deku actually ask him to tell her that? No. Was it a good way to change the fucking subject before Katsuki exploded himself? Absolutely. “And that he misses you”, he added stoically after a thoughtful pause, looking at Inko’s general direction but not meeting her eyes as a grumpy expression overtook his face.

Inko offered Katsuki a small smile.

“I – where is he?”, she asked hesitantly, shyly. Giving her a look that could be interpreted as weird, Katsuki nodded at the direction where Deku was sitting right beside him, and Inko got up and made her way there.

“Mom”, Deku said sadly, outstretching his arms towards her like a fucking baby. His hands phased right through her, as expected. Inko, unaware, hesitantly stretched her own arms to the direction which Katsuki had pointed to, her eyes blankly searching for her son and failing to find him.

“I-Izuku?”, she asked, eyes darting madly across the empty space in front of her. Katsuki watched the scene beside him with a scowl. “Can you hear me?”

“Y-Yeah, mom, I can hear you”, Izuku said, looking at her and trying to embrace her. “I’m right here”.

“Yeah, he’s right there”, Katsuki provided grumpily, not moving from where he was sitting. He was still clutching the rest of the drawings in his hands, and he took the opportunity of Inko being distracted to put them all away in the envelope again. He wasn’t so sure he wanted to see the rest of them. He carefully placed the envelope on the coffee table in front of them and settled back against the couch, still looking profusely annoyed and bored by the ridiculous interaction that was taking place beside him.

Inko got to her knees in front of the couch and stared straight ahead, even though her eyes were trying hard to see her invisible son. Izuku attempted to hold her hands and failed.

“Izuku, baby”, she said with emotion, mustering all the strength she had to smile. “I want you to know how proud I am of you. Despite of all the frights and worries you give me, I’m – I couldn’t be prouder of you. Whatever that horrible villain did to you, I’m sure – I’m s-sure All Might and the teachers at UA will fix it”, she nodded her head with determination. Tears finally escaped her eyes and rolled down her chubby cheeks, and Katsuki found that Deku was crying too, his face stuck in an ugly grimace. He rolled his eyes in annoyance.

Huh. Weird. Even though Deku was crying, Katsuki himself wasn’t. If anything, he felt happy.

From what Katsuki had understood so far, every single emotion Deku felt was capable of making the shitty nerd cry, if it was felt with enough intensity. However, the only feeling from Deku that was capable of making *Katsuki* cry was sadness and variations thereof.

He should probably start taking fucking notes about this kind of shit. *If Deku’s sad, I’ll cry. Gotta ~~hug~~ hold Deku whenever we’re somewhere with inertia or else he’ll stay behind. Seeing his mom and his friends, and eating katsudon, makes him happy. A ridiculous amount of All Might hoodies would probably have the same effect.*

“So hold on tight, ok?”, Inko continued, her eyes looking at Deku without seeing him. “Mom’s here for you whenever you need her. I’m – I’m sorry I can’t touch you or talk to you. But everything will go back to normal soon, I promise. You’re a very brave, strong boy and I’m sure you will get out of this. You have to, ok?”, she smiled past her tears. Deku sobbed, throwing himself on her for a hug and phasing right through her.

Katsuki sighed.

“He’s trying to hug you”, he announced with boredom, because it was kind of pathetic seeing Deku struggle so hard when his mom wasn’t even aware of his efforts. Inko looked up at Katsuki from where she was kneeling and then back at where her son had been sitting, looking conflicted. She stretched her arms.

“Izuku”, she cried, voice tight with emotion and her face scrunched up and more tears flowed on her face. “*Izuku*”, she wailed.

“*Mom*”, Deku wailed back, trying to hug her. Katsuki wanted to jump off the window head first.

Inko continued to try to hug Deku even though she clearly had no idea where he was at, and Deku continued to try to hug her back, even though he was intangible. To Katsuki, who was the only person who could see them both, the scene was laughable, at the very least.

He didn’t feel like laughing, though.

“Is this right? Am I hugging him?”, Inko asked, staring at Katsuki with those big teary green eyes. Katsuki sighed and really, really wanted to offer her a rude retort, but it was clear that it wouldn’t take much for this woman to downright hate him for any small thing he did, and he didn’t want to be kicked out only to have Deku be all gloomy at him for a week. Mentally rolling his eyes, he said shortly, with a bored look:

“Almost”.

It was a lie, but she didn’t know that, and Deku had no ways of telling her.

“This isn’t working”, Deku lowered his head sadly, giving up on the hug altogether. He got back to his feet in silence.

“He’s standing up, now”, Katsuki announced, hating himself and wanting to scream as loudly as he could. Since when had he become a fucking narrator? God, he wanted to leave. Inko stared at him with confusion and stood up herself after a moment, allowing her arms to drop by her sides. She looked around with expectation, but her eyes couldn’t find Deku. A twinge of sadness appeared in Katsuki’s chest, and he couldn’t prevent himself from rolling his eyes this time.

“Look, nerd, I didn’t come all the way over here to have you feel even *sadder*”, he protested with annoyance, standing up and placing himself directly in front of Deku. “You’re here, she’s here – you already *knew* you wouldn’t be able to touch her, so why the fuck be so upset about it?”, he pointed at Inko, who seemed offended at the amount of curse words. “Just enjoy that you’re with your mom or whatever and stop moping over it”, he pushed Deku towards Inko and sat back on the couch, crossing his arms above his chest.

Deku stared at Katsuki with sad eyes, but he eventually tightened his lips into a stern line and nodded, agreeing. He forced a fake smile into his lips – Katsuki knew it was fake because whenever shitty Deku smiled *for real* his eyes shined brightly and little wrinkles appeared on

each side of his eyes – and stared up at his mom, who had sat back down on the couch as well and was looking as miserable as Deku had been a moment before.

“Katsuki-kun”, she said, looking serious and sad at the same time. Katsuki narrowed his eyes at her with annoyance. “I want you to promise me something”.

Katsuki said nothing, staring at her instead. For some childish, irrational reason, he felt furious at Inko for feeling like she had the right to demand anything from him – or, at least, for feeling like she had the right to speak to him in that motherly demanding tone. Inko took a deep breath and bit her lower lip before continuing, her hands gripping at the hem of her apron tightly.

“I have taken you into my house after all those years”, she said, looking serious and intense. Her lower lip was wobbling and her eyes were still teary, but her voice was firm. “I have accepted you here after everything you’ve done to my Izuku”.

Yeah, but just because I brought your shitty son over and you have no other ways of talking to him, Katsuki scoffed silently, thinking to himself.

“And that was not just because you can see and talk to him”, Inko added, as if reading Katsuki’s thoughts through his eyes. Katsuki looked away in anger. “But because I respect you as the young hero you are turning out to be. I am sure that, with the proper guidance, you will leave your boyishness in the past and become the amazing person my Izuku always knew you could be”, she tilted her chin up in defiance, sniffing.

Katsuki suppressed a scowl at the words. He didn’t want Deku’s admiration. He didn’t need it, he didn’t deserve it, why did people insist on shoving it to him?!

He felt angry. He felt furious. He wanted to *leave*. Noticing this, Inko reached over and held his hand in her own. Katsuki stared at her in surprise and confusion, suppressing the urge to break the contact.

“Because of this, I beg of you”, she continued, looking desperate, now. “Treat my Izuku right. I know he isn’t your favorite person, and that you probably wish you hadn’t ended up in this situation with him, of all people, but… As a mother… I’m asking you”, tears started to roll down her cheeks again, “don’t mistreat my boy. Don’t – Don’t think of his happiness as *your* happiness. Think of it as his own”, she sniffed. “For the time you are stuck together, and until the heroes find a solution… Please. Take care of him”, she begged.

Katsuki stared at her. He didn’t know what to say.

“I know my Izuku”, she continued, shaking her head slightly. “He probably feels like an intruder, and he will go out of his way to make sure you are comfortable, despite of his situation”.

Katsuki turned his head to look at Deku, finding an embarrassed, shocked look on his face as he stared at his mom, unaware of Katsuki’s gaze on him. Inko continued, drawing Katsuki’s attention back.

“Just – please, make sure that he is comfortable and happy. I can’t stand the thought of my baby being unhappy after everything he went through in his life”, she sobbed, letting go of Katsuki and burying her face in her hands.

Katsuki continued to stare. He was terrible at comforting people.

“Ok”, he replied after a few moments of complete silence that were only broken by Inko’s eventual sobs. Katsuki hated how uncertain he ended up sounding.

He was confused. There were too many emotions coursing through him at the same time. His own, Deku’s, there was no telling one from the other anymore – and it was overwhelming as fuck. He could barely think straight.

He would sleep *so hard* as soon as he got back to the dorm.

“Thank you, Katsuki-kun”, Inko wiped her tears away with the back of her hands (even though it was useless; new tears just flowed again and replaced the ones she had wiped). She looked up at him with sincerity and a smile that finally seemed to reach her eyes. “I am counting on you”.

Katsuki simply nodded sharply and turned his head away again, glaring at the coffee table.

“A-And –“, Inko continued, sounding almost embarrassed. The small smile hadn’t left her lips yet. “We haven’t seen each other in years but – I think it’s being nice to you”.

“Huh?”, Katsuki frowned at her, not following.

“Spending time with Izuku”, Inko concluded shyly, not meeting Katsuki’s eyes. “You seem… different. In a good way”.

Katsuki’s hand immediately popped with a tiny rage-induced explosion, even though he hadn’t meant to. Inko’s eyes widened in surprise and she gasped.

“Oh!”, she exclaimed, embarrassed. Noticing the absolute rage that had taken over Katsuki’s face, she stood up from the couch slowly, her hands raised in a gesture that indicated she had meant no harm and an awkward smile on her face. “I – I’ll see if the food is ready”, she excused herself, rushing back to the oven. Katsuki stayed where he was, glaring at the coffee table and snarling.

“Kacchan”, Deku tried to say, which only earned another pop from Katsuki’s hand. He backed off.

“*Shut. Up*”, Katsuki growled angrily through gritted teeth.

“Here it is!”, Inko announced cheerfully, placing several bowls on the dinner table and gesturing at Katsuki to come. He stood up from the couch and made his way over to the table, sitting down heavily on the chair and still looking enraged.

He didn’t know why Inko’s comment had bothered him so much, but he couldn’t stop thinking about it. What the fuck had she meant being around Deku was making him different

in a good way? He didn't want to be fucking different – and he would be damned if he ever wanted to be like *Deku*.

Maybe he was getting too soft. Maybe shitty Deku was *making* him that way. Apologizing to people, thanking people, being all polite and posh to Deku's mom – maybe he should put an end to all that shit before people got the wrong impression of him. Before people started thinking Deku was *making him a better person* or whatever the fuck this all seemed like. He didn't need Deku for *shit*, and he certainly didn't need to be better. He was already the fucking *best*.

"I made katsudon!", Inko announced cheerfully – or at least more cheerfully than she had been when Katsuki first arrived. "It's my Izuku's favorite ever since he was small. I – I don't really know how the connection between you two works, but… I hope it makes him happy?", she offered hesitantly.

"It does! Thank you so much, mom!", Izuku exclaimed. Katsuki wanted to punch his fucking teeth in and make him stop looking so much like a nice guy.

"Do you…", Inko asked hesitantly when Katsuki gave no signs that he was about to eat the food. He was still sitting with his rage-scowl on his face, hands tightened into fists on the top of the dining table as he did his best not to explode anything. "Do you not like katsudon, Katsuki-kun?", she asked with uncertainty, probably assuming that Katsuki didn't like that dish and that was the reason why he wasn't eating.

Katsuki took a series of deep breaths to prevent himself from telling Deku's attentive, loving mom to *DIE!!!*, and slowly started to eat, his angry scowl still on his face. Inko wasn't satisfied by this.

"I-If you don't like it, I can make something else", she told him, nervous and clearly not understanding the reason behind his anger. "I only made it because Izuku –"

"I *like* it", he interrupted her, tone sharp and words angry. He ate the katsudon methodically and more angrily than he had to, which probably contributed to Inko's feeling that he didn't like the food.

"Oh… Ok", she blinked blankly at him, starting to eat as well.

A long silence stretched between them. Deku was miraculously silent as Katsuki ate, probably enjoying the katsudon he wasn't even eating.

"I didn't mean to upset you", Inko broke the silence after a few minutes of silent eating, looking embarrassed. "I just meant that being so angry all the time can't be good for you. This is why I think having Izuku around can help you. He is a very calming person".

Katsuki raised a disgusted eyebrow at her, looking at Deku's mom as if she was crazy.

"Deku? A *calming person*?", he asked, incredulous.

“Well, he can be very frantic sometimes”, she admitted in defeat, a small, fond smile on her lips. “But he is also great at being comforting. Whenever I am nervous or distraught… no one can calm me down like Izuku can”, she concluded.

“Which probably happens a fucking lot”, Katsuki muttered under his breath as he chewed.

“I’m sorry, what was that?”, Inko asked, tilting her head towards him. Katsuki wasn’t sure whether she actually hadn’t heard him or if she was just playing dumb to make him repeat his words.

“Nothing”, he huffed, continuing to eat and not looking at her.

“Izuku also feels the need to save everyone”, Inko continued. “And he’s so good at forgiving people. I’m sure he’s been trying to help you manage your anger, hasn’t he?”, she asked fondly. Katsuki was a hair’s breadth away from blowing the table along with its damn katsudon up. Deku’s shitty mom was exactly like shitty Deku – couldn’t drop a subject that made him uncomfortable if her life depended on it.

“Can you two stop talking about me as if I’m not here”, Izuku groaned miserably, hiding his blushing face behind his arms.

“I don’t *need* to manage my anger”, he ended up growling, glaring at her and hoping the angry look would serve as a warning. “Can’t you *see* how fucking *calm* I am?”

Inko chuckled, probably assuming Katsuki was joking.

“Just…”, she trailed off, her smile slowly withering from her face as she gave Katsuki a sad look. “Can you really keep you promise to be good to him?”

“Yeah, I already promised it”, Katsuki ended up losing his patience, muttering angrily. Inko raised her eyebrows at him, and decided to say nothing else.

Katsuki finished his katsudon, pushing the bowl slightly away from him on the table and crossing his arms again as he waited for Inko to finish her own. Once she was done, she collected the bowls and looked at him.

“How did you like it?”

Katsuki didn’t look at her and continued to glare at the table.

“Not spicy enough”, he grumbled.

“*Kacchan*”, Deku reprehended.

“*Fine*. It was good”, he added, still sounding angry. Inko hummed in content and took the bowls to the sink so that she could wash them.

Izuku nudged him with his elbow. Katsuki turned to glare at him and Izuku nodded at his mom, raising his eyebrows and giving Katsuki a disapproving look.

“If I say ‘thanks’ she’ll think it was because her stupid son is so good at *being good* that he immediately makes people better just by being around them”, Katsuki complained, clearly bitter. “Which isn’t fucking true, by the way”, he scoffed. Izuku sighed and rolled his eyes, but Inko didn’t hear them.

Izuku squinted his eyes at Katsuki, waiting.

“Not happening, shitty Deku. Give it up already”, Katsuki scoffed.

Izuku continued to stare.

“Fuck off”.

“Stop swearing in my house!”

“Your mom doesn’t seem to mind”.

“She’s just too polite to complain about it!”

“Then she’s a loser, just like you”.

“Ok, Kacchan, I’m serious now. Don’t say that stuff about my mom”.

“Wow, Deku. You sounded *really* frightening. I’m shaking in fear right now. Are you gonna beat me up?”

“You’re – You’re –“

“I’m what?”

“You’re an ass!”

“Oooh. Let’s see how your mom likes knowing her son is cursing so much”.

“She’ll never believe you”, Deku smirked victoriously.

“You’re so pathetic, have I told you that?”

“Several times over”.

“Good. Don’t forget it”.

“Whatever. Just thank her for the katsudon. It was so good!”

A pause.

“Was it better than mine?”

“What?”

“Her katsudon. Is it better than mine?”

Hesitation.

“You *fucker*. I’ll never cook for you again”.

“But I didn’t even say anything!”

“Your silence said enough”.

“That’s overdramatic, Kacchan”.

“Shut the fuck up. You’ll never taste my katsudon again”.

“But it’s my mom’s cooking! You can’t compete with that!”

“Of *course* I fucking can. I’m the best of the best. What did she do right that I didn’t?”

A pause.

“Just fucking say it already”.

“She… doesn’t put so much… uh… spice…?”

“Fuck. *Off*.”

“I’m sorry! It’s just yours was too spicy! It gave me heartburn for a day!”

“You’re lying”.

“I’m not!”

“I didn’t feel any heartburn, so you’re fucking lying”.

“Because you’re used to it! Or maybe you eat so much spice that you’re constantly having heartburn and you can’t tell the difference anymore!”

“Fuck you. You’re just a wimpy little loser who can’t handle some pepper”.

“If it had just been pepper it would be ok, but you poured *hundreds* of different spices on it!”

“No I didn’t”.

“Yes, you did! I was there when you were cooking!”

“You call *six* spices *hundreds*? What a fucking loser”.

“I’m not used to that many!”

“Too bad for you, then. I ain’t cooking you any fucking katsudon ever again”.

“Don’t be like that! You were the one who asked about it!”

“And you were the one who tossed the chance of ever tasting my amazing cooking on the trash *forever*”.

“*Kachaaaan*!”

“No use whining about it, now”.

“Don’t be like that!”

“Go to hell”.

“Stop being jealous of my mom!”

“What the *fuck*? I’m *not*!”

“Yes, you are! Just put less spice on the next time –“

“Don’t tell me what to do, and especially don’t tell me how to *fucking* cook –“

“I’m just trying to give you some helpful advice!”

“Keep your shitty advice for yourself, you babbling fucking nerd!”

“I really don’t know what my mom meant when she said you’re different, because I don’t see any improvement! You just keep yelling at me whenever I open my mouth like you always do!”

“That’s because I repeatedly tell you to shut the fuck up and you repeatedly refuse to listen!”

“Katsuki-kun”, Inko approached him with a frown, having finished with the dishes. She was frowning and bore a confused expression on her face. “Is everything alright? Are you two having an argument?”

“No”, Katsuki said with a scowl at the same time Deku exclaimed “Yes!”

Inko continued to stare at him with confusion and something akin to disapproval in her eyes. Katsuki rolled his eyes and scoffed, standing up from his seat by the dinner table. Deku stared at him with a grumpy expression that had nothing to do with Katsuki’s own but still managed to give off the same emotion.

“We weren’t having an argument”, he reassured Inko, standing awkwardly in front of her before gesturing to the door. “I think we should get going, now. Aizawa sensei told us not to stay out to long”.

“We’re going already? But I didn’t even take a look at my bedroom!”, Deku whined.

“And what the *fuck* are you supposed to do at your bedroom, cry like a baby while you try to pick up things and *fail*?”, Katsuki growled at him, forgetting Inko was there for a moment. Deku did cringe at Katsuki’s loud tone, but continued to stare at him with defiance. Inko, however, was giving him a very disapproving look.

“I’ll see you to the door”, she said sternly, looking offended and tired. Katsuki huffed and shoved his hands into his pockets as he followed her, glaring at everything he could get his eyes on. Stupid house. Stupid furniture. Stupid Deku.

“Kacchan”, Deku followed him close, an urgent look in his eyes. Katsuki didn’t look at him, so he continued. He looked reluctant, as if he didn’t want to ask Katsuki for a favor so soon after their discussion, but it wasn’t like he had any other option. “Before we go… Can you say something to my mom?”

He didn’t offer Deku any sort of response other than a nod so subtle that it could have been missed by a less attentive eye. They reached the door and Inko opened it slightly, blocking Katsuki’s way and worrying at her lower lip as if there was more she wanted to say, but didn’t know how. He took the opportunity of her hesitation to relay Deku’s message.

“Deku wants you to know –“, he started, but upon Inko’s increasingly disapproving glare he stopped, rolled his eyes, and sighed heavily. “*Whatever*. *He* wants me to tell you not to worry about him. He’s not in pain, he’s doing okay, and we’ll find a way out of this. He also rambled a lot about you taking care of yourself and sleeping more or some crap – *okay*, some *thing* like that. Anyway – he wants you to know he loves you, etc.”, he concluded, bearing a half-bored, half-grumpy look. Inko eyed him with apprehension.

“Thank you, Katsuki-kun”, she said, bowing her head slightly. “For bringing my Izuku to see me and for relaying his message to me”.

“Don’t mention it”, Katsuki said, trying to walk past her in order to leave. God, was he *tired*.

Inko grabbed his wrist before he managed to walk out of the apartment, in a very similar way to how Deku usually grabbed him. Katsuki’s primal instinct was to pull away aggressively, but he managed to control himself before he ended up doing something rude. He stared – or rather, glared – at Inko, and she stared back with a weird expression in her eyes that was very similar to the one she had worn when she asked Katsuki why he was truly there.

“I know you’ve already promised to take care of my Izuku”, she started. Irritation boiled deep in Katsuki’s chest, and one of his hands tightened into a fist. How many times was she going to ask him the same thing over and over?

“Yeah”, he said bitterly, through gritted teeth. Couldn’t she just stop staring at him with those big fucking eyes?

“But if – if you don’t”, she said, in a tone that was probably supposed to be threatening. “If I hear you mistreated him, or made him suffer, I’ll –“, she bit her lower lip, lowering her head and shaking it with the weight of her emotion. She looked like she was forcing herself to say the words, hesitating for a moment before raising her head again and staring deep into Katsuki’s eyes. *Fuck*. “I won’t forgive you this time. And – and I – I won’t let it go as easily as I did b-back when you were in school. I won’t”, she tilted her chin slightly up as if to emphasize the seriousness behind her words. “I’ll inform the school board of it and – and y-you’ll have to face the consequences”.

Katsuki continued to stare at her, not sure how to feel about that.

“Mom”, Izuku whispered softly, almost in admiration. Katsuki wanted to punch him in the stomach, but restrained himself.

“Ok”, Katsuki responded after a few seconds of silence. What else could he tell Deku’s mom in that situation? *Go fuck yourself for trying to defend your son*?

He kind of did want to say that, but stayed quiet.

Inko nodded simply, stepping to the side and letting go of Katsuki’s wrist. His path was clear, but, for some reason, he couldn’t move. He was glued to his feet.

“Kacchan?”, Deku asked, frowning.

Katsuki stared at the floor, so many feelings coursing through him that he couldn’t make out one from the other.

I think I probably forgave you already

I won’t forgive you this time

It’s easier if I just forgive you without you actually having to apologize. But even if I do that, the pain won’t just go away –

Why the fuck did the Midoriyas insist on forgiving Katsuki for things he hadn’t asked their forgiveness for?

He never asked them for anything. He never asked Deku to forgive him for his shitty behavior back at school; he never asked Inko to forgive him for the way he treated her shitty son. He *never* asked them. He didn’t owe them. He may have been a piece of shit to Deku back at school, but that was in the past. And what’s in the past stays in the past. Katsuki couldn’t change any of that now, and there’s no use whining about stuff you can’t change. All he could do was try not to be as shitty to Deku as he used to be, even though the nerd with his annoying antics made this task *extremely fucking hard*.

But if it was truly all in the past, why was Deku still hurt? Why could Katsuki feel the pain emanating from him?

His mind wandered back to Deku’s drawings of him. Deku’s admiration for him, Deku’s near adoration for him, even though he did nothing, *nothing* other than hurt him and put him down. Tell him horrible things. *Do* terrible things to him.

Was Deku fucked up in the head or something? Why the hell would he admire Katsuki, after everything he did? He knew he was fucking amazing and admiration for him was something he was extremely used to, but never in his life had he bullied someone as hard as he bullied Deku.

Why did Deku fill made him feel repulse when he only ever made Deku feel admiration?

When did he actually start hating Deku?

“Uh, Kacchan…”, Deku tried again, giving Katsuki a worried look. Blinking blankly and snapping back to reality, Katsuki looked at Deku and then at his mom, who had a similar concerned look on her face. He felt uncomfortable and embarrassed by the attention – even though it was something he was used to, but not in *that* way –, and promptly shoved his hands into his pockets as he turned his head away.

“Thanks for the food”, he said simply, as if he hadn’t just been silently glaring at the floor in deep thought for god knows how long. “I’ll see if I can bring Deku over again”.

Before Inko could say anything – or even give him another disapproving look for the use of the hated nickname –, Katsuki turned on his heels and left, Deku trailing behind him.

“Kacchan?”, Deku asked again as they were leaving, that stupid, unreasonable fucking concern etched all over his voice and his face. “Are you ok?”

“Just leave me the fuck alone, Deku”, was all he bothered to say before engaging in a very silent, very grumpy travel back to the UA.

Deku, for the first time in his life, knew better than to push it.

He didn’t say anything as they took the train back to the UA and held Izuku in his arms again, or when they arrived at UA, or when they headed to the dorms, or when he entered his bedroom. The first time Katsuki talked to him after they left his apartment was to say “I’m going to take a nap”, before plopping down on the bed and falling asleep in the matter of seconds.

Izuku couldn’t say he blamed him. He was feeling very tired himself, and the first train ride to his apartment had been extremely exhausting. If their theory that going through extreme, intense emotions was the cause of their exhaustion was right, then the conversation they had had with his mom was probably what had taken its toll on Kacchan. Now, he was fast asleep on his bed while Izuku watched the steady rise and fall of his chest, as well as the way the explosive boy’s mouth hung wide open and soft snores came out of his parted lips.

Izuku smiled softly with fondness. Kacchan rarely slept with his mouth open and he certainly didn’t snore, so the fact that he was doing so could only mean that he was extremely tired.

Izuku’s smile faltered as he realized that it was his fault Kacchan was tired.

Tokoyami-kun’s theory started to make more sense to Izuku now. And if he was really draining Kacchan…

But what could he do? He didn't know how to get back to his body. He would if he could. But at the same time, he didn't want Kacchan to take the most of it just because he was too helpless to find a solution and save himself.

Helpless. Defenseless. *Deku*.

Izuku sighed. He had loved seeing his mom, and he had loved that Kacchan had actually taken the time and put the effort of taking him there. He knew Kacchan had only done it so that Izuku felt happier, which by consequence meant *he* would feel happier, but still.

It had been nice. It had been really nice. The combo of seeing his mom + eating his mom's katsudon would have been enough to make Izuku hop around like a bunny.

He didn't feel like hopping, though. There was a sort of melancholy inside him that Izuku wasn't entirely sure it was only his own.

Why was Kacchan sad?

He ran a hand across his tired face and then combed his hair back with his fingers. His hair was growing a lot. He didn't know what he could do to make it better and prevent it from falling above his eyes.

Actually, he didn't know how to make *anything* better.

Watching Kacchan sleep (and picturing in his mind the way his guttural voice would sound as he screamed "*stop staring at me, nerd, that's creepy as f****!!!*"), Izuku tried to think of what possible reason could have made him feel such melancholy. Izuku could feel it himself, mirroring Kacchan's emotions, and he knew the sadness wasn't his, this time.

He had been embarrassed about Kacchan seeing his pictures and his drawings, but he also felt that this was something they needed to talk about. He was afraid of what Kacchan's reaction would be if he brought that subject up, though. He had looked so upset and angry when he saw the drawings – knowing he was feeling so sad, Izuku didn't want to bring the subject up himself.

But he really wanted to know what was going through Kacchan's mind. Just looking at him, Izuku had no idea.

He was also worried about his mom. She had been right – there was no logic in not allowing her into the UA, but allowing *them* out. Sparing personnel to follow them around and protect them in the open, where they were way more vulnerable to possible attacks, sounded a lot more troublesome than simply allowing his mom inside the school grounds, where it was safe and protected. Something told Izuku the reasons behind her banishment were way deeper and more complex than she had been told by the teachers. Maybe this was their way to keep her in the dark and not stress her out about Izuku's situation.

But then, that would mean Izuku's situation was a lot worse than he thought it was. Aizawa sensei's words returned to his mind and he found himself getting more and more worried. *Another student's life is on the line.*

What weren't they telling his mom? What weren't they telling *him*? Was his life actually on the line?

He stretched and sighed, deciding there was no use in dwelling over such a subject for the time being. He wouldn't be able to do anything about it until Kacchan was awake, and he certainly wasn't about to go and wake the boy up. Izuku had also been drained from his energy after the train incident, and, despite his worry and the thoughts rushing through his mind, he was feeling tired enough to take a nap as well. After all, it would be no good if just Kacchan rested and he didn't, like they had been doing back when Izuku was sleeping on the floor. They both needed to be well rested so that they could –

So that they –

Oh.

Oh.

A sudden thought blossomed in Izuku's mind.

Maybe they weren't *only* sharing feelings.

Maybe they were also *exchanging* them.

Thinking about it, Izuku found that it made sense. Whenever he felt overwhelmingly sad, Kacchan cried. Whenever Kacchan felt overwhelmingly angry, Izuku cursed and yelled. And whenever one of them had been tired, the other took the worst of it.

Their problem so far was that they hadn't been finding balance. Either Izuku felt too sad, and the sadness ended up manifesting itself in Kacchan, or Kacchan felt too angry, and the anger manifested itself in Izuku. When Izuku felt upset or normally sad, Kacchan didn't cry, and when Kacchan felt his usual grumpiness and annoyance (rather than burning rage), Izuku didn't yell.

This was why it didn't matter if just Kacchan was happy or just Izuku was happy – they *both* needed to be happy. Izuku imagined their emotions as being water inside a cup that was inside a larger cup. If the water in the first cup overflowed, it ended up leaking into the larger one. And Izuku was used to dealing with his own sadness – just as Kacchan was used to dealing with his own anger. But that didn't mean Izuku knew how to deal with *Kacchan's* anger, or that Kacchan knew how to deal with *Izuku's* sadness. These were both alien feelings for them, feelings that weren't their own, and that consequentially ended up upsetting them more than they upset their actual owners.

They needed to find balance for the cup not to overflow. They needed to control their emotions. Not only Kacchan needed to control his anger – Izuku also needed to control his misery whenever he thought about his body and his friends. Whenever he thought about his mom.

The hard part would be convincing Kacchan he needed to control his anger. From what Izuku could tell, he was already having a hard time controlling himself around him and probably

thought that giving in to Izuku's requests for him to be politer and gentler to people were signs of weakness. Izuku could tell Kacchan all about his theory, but he wasn't sure the boy would listen to him. When had he ever?

Still, this was a better solution than the outcome of Tokoyami-kun's theory. If they found a way to balance their emotions so that they didn't end up overwhelming one another, they could finally stop feeling so tired all the time. Izuku knew how much Katsuki hated having to take power naps all the time – he could feel it himself. And even though he didn't have much to do, being a ghost and all, Izuku also felt pretty sick of having to sleep all the time.

He stood up and made his way to the bed, carefully climbing beside Katsuki, even though he knew his phantom body wouldn't be able to rattle the mattress. Relief immediately coursed through Izuku as he lay down, the soft mattress of Kacchan's bed soothing his aching back.

His back wasn't hurting so bad, now, but it was still a bit sore after the train stunt. As Izuku closed his eyes, allowing his thoughts to flow freely and lull him to sleep, he made a mental reminder to ask Kacchan to take a look at the scar in his back when they both woke up.

Izuku was so tired he didn't even realize Kacchan had forgotten to put up the pillow fort to separate them.

Katsuki woke up with a silent gasp.

As soon as his eyes opened, he forgot all about the dream, but his heart was still racing and his fists were still clenched. His mind may have been erased of whatever his subconscious came up with to frighten him, but his body was still showing the signs of the fight or flight instinct his dream had activated.

He took in a deep breath to calm himself and assessed his surroundings. He was in his bedroom; the curtains were closed (so he couldn't tell what time it was) and there was a curious lack of pillows separating his side of the bed from Deku's.

As his sluggish mind regained proper consciousness and got rid of the sleep that addled it, he realized that Deku's face was buried in his chest.

What the *fuck*.

Katsuki lowered his face in order to see better what the hell was going on, and found that not only was Deku's face buried in his fucking chest while he slept, but his arms were also

thrown around Katsuki's torso, holding him in a – a cuddle? Katsuki didn't want to fucking call it that. *Hell* no.

He *knew* it. He knew it that the moment he removed the fucking pillow fort, the nerd would take advantage of it. Katsuki had been too tired to even think about putting it up before he fell asleep, so the damn nerd had to go right the fuck ahead and hug him, right? He had to fucking break into Katsuki's personal space like that, the little piece of shit.

(Katsuki promptly ignored the fact that he, in his sleep, had also thrown an arm around Deku's torso, keeping him in place. Before the boy could wake up and realize this, he slowly removed his arm from the top of Deku, looking suspiciously flushed).

He needed to get the fuck out of that bed before Deku woke up and realized the embarrassing situation he had put themselves in. He needed to get the fuck out of that bed before Deku woke up and felt smug about cuddling Katsuki. He was sure as hell the nerd would try to shove it in his face, like he always did.

However, staring down at Deku's sleeping face, Katsuki found himself unable to move.

The boy's lips were slightly parted and he looked peaceful. His freckles stood out on his face as he slept, hair messily falling over one of his eyes and almost all the way down to his cheek. The fucking nerd needed to get a damn haircut, *stat*. He was starting to look ridiculous with his curls looking like that.

Deku's breathing had evened out during his sleep and it was mimicking Katsuki's. Way too fucking weird for his liking, but he found that he didn't have it in him to wake Deku up. Because at least he was breathing. At least his chest wasn't as still as it had – as it had been –

Katsuki took a deep breath and calmed himself. He didn't know where those memories were coming from, but he wanted them fucking *gone*.

He decided not to wake Deku up.

Because he needed to be well-rested. That was all. For Katsuki not to be tired, Deku couldn't be tired, too. That was the only fucking reason he wouldn't wake him up. That, and because he didn't want the nerd to find out they had ended up accidentally cuddling like a pair of – a pair of –

Honestly, *fuck* Deku.

Katsuki gently removed Deku's arm from where it was drooped above his waist and carefully put a pillow beneath his hair to replace his chest – just because he didn't want the nerd to wake up; otherwise he would have let his ugly head drop down like a sack of fucking potatoes, he *would*. Deku had the audacity to fucking whine at Katsuki's absence – what the *fuck* was that about?!?!?! –, but he didn't wake up, rather snuggling closer to the pillow and burying his face on it instead. He sighed heavily in content and kept on sleeping.

Katsuki found himself staring, until he *realized* he was fucking staring, and turned away so angrily that, if looks could make things blow up, his entire studying desk would have been

obliterated in that exact same moment.

What the fucking fuck. What the fuck.

That was all Katsuki could think.

What the *fuck*. What the *fuck?! What. The.* ***Fuck***.

what the fuck what the fuck what the fuck what the fuck what the fuck what the fuck what the fuck what the fuck what the fuck what the fuck what the fuck what the fuck what the fuck what the fuck what the fuck what the fuck what the fuck what the fuck what the fuck what the fuck.

He was feeling a lot of things at the same time. Where was that all coming from, for fuck's sake?! He could tell the things he was feeling weren't a mirror of Deku, because Deku was fucking asleep, and he didn't look like he was having a nightmare or any of that shit.

So why the hell was Katsuki feeling so scared?

And, most importantly, what was he scared of?

He didn't want to know the answer to the question. He didn't want to know any fucking thing at all. He didn't want to know why waking up to find out he and Deku had fucking snuggled in their sleep as if it was the most natural fucking thing in the world had made him feel so – so fucking – lost? Vulnerable? Confused? Angry? Fucking *batshit*?!

Katsuki tightened his hands into fists and growled in anger and frustration. Just what the *fuck*, Deku. Why was his damn heart *racing*?!

Before he could think better, he grabbed his phone and texted Kirishima. Kirishima knew about feelings. He was about the only person Katsuki actually trusted.

From: Bakubro

Loser

From: Bakubro

Are you there?

From: Shitty Hair

Hey bro

From: Shitty Hair

How are ya?

From: Shitty Hair

Why weren’t you at the afternoon classes? Did smth happen?

From: Bakubro

Shut up

From: Bakubro

None of your business

From: Shitty Hair

:/

From: Shitty Hair

Is everything alright tho??

From: Bakubro

Yes

From: Bakubro

No

From: Bakubro

I don’t know

From: Shitty Hair

Ooooooooooooohhhhhhhhhh

From: Shitty Hair

Is this one of those rare Bakugou-talks-about-his-emotional-constipation moments???

From: Bakubro

Fuck you

From: Bakubro

Don’t know why I even bothered

From: Shitty Hair

Noooooo

From: Shitty Hair

Come back

From: Shitty Hair

Bakugou I was jokinggggggg

From: Shitty Hair

I'm sorry

From: Shitty Hair

You can talk to me

From: Shitty Hair

You know that bro

From: Shitty Hair

Sorry for the joke I know this is hard for you

From: Shitty Hair

Bakugouuuuuuuu

From: Bakubro

Never mind, Kirishima

From: Shitty Hair

I love it when you call me Kirishima but not in that tone :/

From: Bakubro

This is a fucking text conversation

From: Bakubro

There is no tone, dumbfuck

From: Shitty Hair

Yes there is :/

From: Shitty Hair

And you're upset :/

From: Shitty Hair

And I'm sorry :/

From: Bakubro

I'm not fucking upset

From: Bakubro

I just changed my mind

From: Bakubro

So never fucking mind

From: Bakubro

Just stop by later to give me the notes for today's afternoon classes

From: Shitty Hair

Will you tell me what's wrong when I stop by? :/

From: Bakubro

No

From: Bakubro

And stop using that fucking upset face

From: Shitty Hair

:/

From: Bakubro

I'm gonna block you

From: Shitty Hair

Noooooooo

From: Shitty Hair

Ok I'll stop :D

Read at 19:24

From: Shitty Hair

Hey u still there?

From: Shitty Hair

Hey bakubro

From: Shitty Hair

Heyyyyyyyyyyy

From: Shitty Hair

:/

From: Bakubro

What do you want

From: Shitty Hair

Just tell me what's wrong!! You can trust me! I wont make jokes anymore I promise

From: Bakubro

Go die in a corner

From: Shitty Hair

Rude

From: Shitty Hair

C'mon bro we're bros!!! bros share feelings with each other

From: Shitty Hair

It's manly

From: Bakubro

stfu

From: Shitty Hair

You can tell me anything you want

From: Shitty Hair

Is it about Midoriya?

From: Shitty Hair

Are you two finally figuring your shit out?

From: Shitty Hair

Is that why you didn't go to class?

From: Bakubro

I'm feeling really pissed rn so unless you want me to go all the way over your ugly bedroom and blow you face off just leave it alone

From: Bakubro

I was gonna tell you before you pissed me off

From: Shitty Hair

Noooooooooo

From: Shitty Hair

God damn my timeless sense of humor

From: Bakubro

Quit the fucking drama

From: Bakubro

I'll tell you about it later when you're not being so fucking annoying and when I know you won't go around running your damn mouth about it to everyone

From: Bakubro

It's no big deal so stop making such a fucking fuss

From: Shitty Hair

Ok :/

From: Shitty Hair

Thanks for trusting me bakubro!! I won't let you down!

From: Bakubro

What are you a fucking car salesman

From: Shitty Hair

Someone’s cranky

From: Bakubro

Fuck off

From: Shitty Hair

You know you love me

Read at 19:32

Chapter End Notes

(me, sobbing desperately) is this good? IS THIS GOOD? is this GOOD?

(i hope it is)

Chapter 9: Scars

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku woke up to a bang and loud whispers.

He squinted his eyes and lifted his head from the bed, vision still blurry from sleep and mind confused and sluggish. He could see Kacchan's silhouette standing in front of the door, his back dark in contrast with the bright light coming from the hallway. In front of him there were two other people that, Izuku couldn't be sure, but looked like Kaminari and Mina. He frowned.

"If we go, will you get the fuck away from here and leave me alone?", Kacchan asked in what Izuku assumed was supposed to be a low tone, but his whispered voice was so loud that he might as well have been speaking normally.

"Don't be so grumpy about it! It's going to be fun!", Mina responded, her whispering voice considerably lower than Kacchan's (but still loud enough for Izuku to hear it from the bed). Kacchan tried to close the door, but Kaminari kept him from doing so by placing his foot in front of it and blocking the way.

"You don't even have to cook if you don't want to, man", Kaminari added. "I was kidding when I asked".

"But if you do want to, that'd be great", Mina interrupted him. "Just saying".

"You can just come over and hang out with us! Sero and I are providing some booze; you can't miss it!"

"That's not even fucking allowed, dunce face", Kacchan retorted, sounding impatient. "You all really think Aizawa sensei is going to let a bunch of underage students get wasted at the dorm in the middle of a school night?"

"He doesn't have to *know*", Kaminari said, a subtle – yet fearful – warning in his tone. "As long as no one tells!", he added conspicuously.

"And how the fuck are you supposed to buy booze with those baby faces, huh?", Katsuki scoffed, shaking his head in disapproval. "Y'all are underage".

"Don't worry about it, we got it all settled!", Kaminari placed a hand on Katsuki's shoulder as if to tranquilize him. Katsuki immediately shrugged away from the touch and gave Kaminari a warning glare. "Just make sure you come and have some fun with us! You spend all the time locked in your room, man!", he added despite of the look in Katsuki's face.

"Yeah!", Mina exclaimed in agreement. "It would do you and Midoriya good to have some fun!"

“What does the Hand Guy have to say about that?”, Kacchan scoffed.

“About the party?”, Kaminari frowned.

“About the *booze*, shithead”, Katsuki sighed.

“Why are you so worked up about the booze, man?”, Kaminari frowned, smiling at the same time.

“Iida-kun doesn’t have to know, either!”, Mina responded, mischief in her tone. “As long as we are subtle about it!“

“Since when have any of our shitty friends ever been *subtle*, Raccoon Eyes?”, Kacchan pointed out with annoyance.

There was a pause. Izuku couldn’t quite see anyone’s faces from where he was still lying on the bed.

“*What*?”, Kacchan added angrily – and possibly a bit louder than he had intended – when neither of the friends at his door said anything else. “Why are you giving me those damn looks?”

“N-Nothing, it’s just –“, Mina started, her voice sounded suspiciously wobbly. Izuku couldn’t tell if she was actually about to cry or if she was faking it for dramatics. “Y-You said ‘*our*”, she sniffed.

“*Huh*?”, Kacchan asked, that familiar tone in his voice that warned whoever was speaking to him to be careful with their answer if they didn’t want any explosions to take place.

“You always say ‘*your* friends’”, Kaminari explained.

“And now you said ‘our’!”, Mina exclaimed cheerfully, even if her voice was still wobbly.

“That’s some real development, Kacchan!”, Kaminari added, giving Katsuki a thumbs up.

Instead of responding, Katsuki simply ignored Kaminari’s foot serving as a door holder and put all his weight on it, trying to push the door close. Mina and Kaminari struggled together to keep it open, but they were slowly losing against Katsuki’s resolve.

“Just come over! Pretty please!”, Mina asked, her voice squeaky as she put all her strength and effort into keeping the door open for just a few more seconds. “Kiri will be so upset if you don’t!”

“His fucking birthday only in a week, so I don’t know why the hell you’re all so desperate about it already”, Katsuki grunted as he continued to push the door. Izuku figured he probably wasn’t putting all his strength into it, otherwise Kaminari’s foot would have been crushed already.

“Because usually *he’s* the one who convinces you to socialize!”, Kaminari protested through gritted teeth as he struggled against Katsuki’s strength. “And it’s a surprise party, so he won’t

be able to invite you himself! Someone had to do it for him!"

"We knew we would need time to talk you into going", Mina added. "So better start already, heh?"

"I'll only go if you get the *fuck* out of my room", Kacchan said and, with a strong push, he successfully shoved Kaminari and Mina away from the door.

"But we're not even insiiiiide!", they protested at the exact same time Katsuki slammed the door closed on their faces. Izuku flinched in surprise at the loud sound.

Katsuki stomped his way back to his studying desk angrily, sitting on his chair and not looking at Izuku as he turned his laptop's screen back on and continued whatever he had been doing before Kaminari and Mina knocked on his door. It didn't take him too long to address Izuku, never looking at him.

"I know you're awake, nerd".

Izuku felt himself blush and was thankful for the darkness in the room that prevented Kacchan from noticing the pink tone of his cheeks. The only source of light was coming from the laptop and from Kacchan's lamp beside it.

"How do you know that?", Izuku asked with curiosity. Was it because of their bond? Could Kacchan simply feel that Izuku was awake, too? If that was the case, then could Izuku feel when Kacchan was asleep/awake? Were they able to wake each other up? Had Izuku woken up because Kacchan was awake too? No, but if that was the case, then they would have to fall asleep at the same time, right? And Izuku knew that wasn't true. Maybe the bond didn't work for falling asleep, but it did for waking up? But then, it was normal for him to wake up before Kacchan, without having him wake, too, and the other way around was also true. Maybe this was a new development in the quirk that bond their souls? Maybe they were becoming more dependent? Maybe Kacchan –

"There's no way you'd still be asleep after I slammed the fucking door like that", Katsuki explained matter-of-factly, cutting Izuku out of his mental rambling.

Oh.

Ok, then. That made more sense.

"I – I actually woke up before that. You whisper really loudly", Izuku admitted, sitting up on the bed and rubbing his eyes with sleepiness. He tried to remove his hair from the top of his eyes, but his green curls just fell back down, blocking his vision. He tried again a few times before giving up with a resigned sigh.

"No, I don't", Katsuki scoffed, sounding almost offended. "Your ears are just way too fucking sensitive".

"No, they're not!", Izuku protested with humor in his voice.

“You’re not making any sense, dumbass. How can it be loud if it’s a whisper? Stop embarrassing yourself”, Katsuki reproved. He still wasn’t looking at Izuku, eventually typing something down in his laptop and scrolling through some text that Izuku couldn’t make out from where he was sitting on the bed. Kacchan was wearing his reading glasses, so he probably couldn’t notice Izuku staring at him through his peripheral vision, right?

“It’s only funny because whispers aren’t meant to be loud, but yours is”, Izuku explained, crossing his legs on the bed and staring at Kacchan’s face, which was glowing white due to the light of the monitor in the dark.

Izuku was still struggling to get used to seeing Kacchan wearing glasses. They had known each other for so long, and yet it took Izuku 15 years to find out Kacchan wore them… But again, the distance between them had always been too far for Izuku to find that sort of detail out.

He lowered his head as he remembered his drawings, his pictures, and the look in Kacchan’s face. It was embarrassing.

“Maybe I was just trying to wake you up on purpose so that you’d get your lame ass out of my bed. How about that?”, Kacchan scoffed. Izuku looked up at him, squinting his eyes.

Why wasn’t Kacchan looking at him?

It was usual for Kacchan to ignore him or act as if he wasn’t there, but he rarely avoided looking at Izuku. Usually, when he was angry, he glared or fulminated him with his crimson eyes. When he really wanted to ignore Izuku, he didn’t look at him, but didn’t talk to him, either. Now, he was speaking to Izuku normally, but never meeting his eyes. For some reason, it bothered the boy.

Izuku thought back to the events from the previous day. Even though Kacchan seemed troubled by the pictures and he drawings he saw, and even though he had been uncannily silent on their trip back to UA, he had still looked at Izuku. Sure, Katsuki didn’t have many reasons to, since he barely spoke a word to him after they left his apartment, but still… it hadn’t been like *this*. Now, it looked like he was downright avoiding looking at Izuku’s general direction whatsoever.

Maybe he had thought better about the pictures and the drawings? Maybe he was only *now* feeling embarrassed, or angry, or upset by them? Maybe he woke up before Izuku did and mulled things over? Maybe he realized, finally, just how cruel he’d been to Izuku and how everything he did throughout their childhood had upset him and left a mark on him?

No, that wasn’t Kacchan. Kacchan wasn’t evasive – he was conflictive. If there was a problem, he either screamed about it, fought about it, or – in rarer stances, such as the one from two nights before – talked about it.

Izuku thought back to the heart-to-heart hey had shared on that day after the fight in the kitchen. Even though Kacchan had still acted like his short-fused, angry self, he had also sounded more… Empathetic. Comprehensive, perhaps? He never actually apologized to Izuku, but he promised to try and be better. If he had managed to talk to Izuku about their

discussion and clarify things two days before, why wasn't it he doing it now? They didn't actually have a discussion, but still, Izuku felt the urgent need to talk about their visit to his mom. About the train ride, about the photos and the drawings, about their childhood. He needed to talk about it. He wanted to.

But how could he talk to Kacchan without being yelled at? Without yelling *back*? Now, after spending days and days and days glued to Kacchan and having no one else as company, Izuku understood more and more why Kacchan had decided to fight him instead of properly asking him about One For All and All Might. It was sad, but it seemed like they were only able to communicate through violence. Through screaming. Through punches. Through fights. Izuku tried to imagine himself telling Kacchan "hey, I think we should have a chat about the visit to my mom" and found out that he couldn't.

Did Kacchan feel the same way? Was that why he wasn't looking at him?

Maybe Izuku had said something in his sleep that added to the weight of Kacchan seeing his drawings. Izuku knew he was a mumbling person, and he also knew he talked in his sleep, so maybe that was it? But still, the idea of having Kacchan giving him the cold shoulder over something he said in his sleep felt weird. It would be more likely for him to tease Izuku, or confront him about it. Act coldly to him, by replying to his questions but not meeting his eyes? Not so much.

Kacchan only ever ignored Izuku when he despised him.

Was that it? Had Kacchan gone back to despising him? Had he gone back to thinking Izuku was a useless, weak, pathetic little nerd who amounted to nothing? Had he gone back to thinking Izuku was nothing more than a pebble, and not a worthy rival? Had seeing Izuku's drawings – Izuku's weakness, Izuku's vulnerability – really earned that effect in Kacchan?

Why did he care so much about what Kacchan thought, anyway? Izuku felt embarrassed to realize that minutes had passed since Kacchan last spoke up, and that he had spent this entire time lost in deep thought and quite probably mumbling to himself. He looked up expecting to see Kacchan's death glare and an angry snarl on his face as he told Izuku to *stop f****** mumbling*, but Kacchan was still staring at his laptop with indifference, not even aware of Izuku's crisis.

Izuku felt embarrassed. He was freaking out so hard about Kacchan, and Kacchan wasn't even acknowledging his general existence.

Why did he want Kacchan to acknowledge him?

For years, as they grew up together, there was nothing Izuku wanted more than for Kacchan to acknowledge him. Not notice him – he already noticed Izuku enough, pushing him into lockers, burning his notebooks down, mocking him and humiliating him –, but to *acknowledge* him. To see him as his equal. To see him as a worthy rival.

Now, that had finally happened. Kacchan still cursed at him, and yelled at him, and talked to him as if he was inferior, but Izuku could notice how their relationship had changed. How their dynamics had changed. Because even if Kacchan still did all that – like he did to all the

students at UA –, he clearly saw Izuku for what he truly was, now – someone capable of surpassing him. Someone capable of becoming number one hero in his place.

Izuku didn't want Kacchan to go back to seeing him as a quirkless loser.

Maybe that was why he was freaking out so hard? They had been making progress, the two of them, even if it was painfully, painstakingly slow. Izuku didn't want all that progress to go to waste – he didn't want to go back to stage zero. He didn't want his dynamics with Kacchan to go back to what they used to be, not now that they were sharing the same rank, not now that they were *finally* headed to something that resembled more an actual friendship than any interaction that they had shared in the past 11 years.

Izuku stared at Katsuki, noticing the way the white light of the laptop screen was reflected in his crimson eyes, noticing the way his eyebrows weren't creased in anger or annoyance while he was distracted, noticing the way he was tapping a rhythm on the desk with the pencil he was holding, noticing the way he looked beautiful and different in glasses, younger, nerdier, cleverer. Kacchan had always been so clever, Izuku hadn't thought it possible for him to look even more so. He wouldn't have been able to witness any of those things a month before, or a year before. Even though it was a sad conclusion, he realized he was only now getting to know the *real* Kacchan, even though they had met over a decade ago. All because of a villain's quirk. All because of an accident.

He ended up staring at Kacchan for a long time, just taking him in. Analyzing him down to the smallest detail, assessing him, studying him. Remembering him. The way he squinted his eyes in order to read something he hadn't understood. The way he gave a tiny scowl whenever he read something he disagreed with. The way he constantly changed his facial expression according to the different emotions he felt, the way he was so sincere and honest with his thoughts.

Kacchan was an open book that Izuku didn't know how to read.

Maybe Izuku thought too much about things. Maybe he overanalyzed too much. Maybe he should try to have a more objective thinking, like Kacchan did. But the truth was that Kacchan always wore his heart on his face, but Izuku just didn't know how to interpret it.

Kacchan had known that taking Izuku to see his mom would make him feel happier. He had known that telling Izuku's friends what he requested would make him feel happier. Those were things Izuku had commented without any expectation that Kacchan would actually deliver – especially the part of taking him to see his mom, as a *surprise* –, and that Kacchan had done anyway. And yes, maybe he had only done it out of a selfish attempt to preserve his own happiness, but still. He had paid attention to Izuku. He had listened to what Izuku said and thought of the best way to put that information into use.

He didn't know why he wanted to be friends with Kacchan so bad. Kacchan was right to feel confused about Izuku's wish – all he ever did was mistreat Izuku throughout their whole lives. Rationally, there should be no reason for Izuku to want to be closer to him – if anything, he should want to stay as far away from Kacchan as possible. And yet…

Who was he kidding? He knew exactly why he wanted to be friends with Kacchan.

Kacchan was amazing. He was arrogant, rude, insolent, and a downright asshat, but he was *spectacular*. The way he controlled his quirk, the way he thought quickly in battle, the way he had mastered his physical abilities, the way his resolve to be the best was unfaltering… Even though his arrogance was ugly, he wasn't entirely wrong to feel arrogant per say. The way he acted about it was… reproachable, but it wasn't misguided. Kacchan thought he was the best, and he truly was.

(For now.)

Izuku had told him as much during their fight at the training grounds, but he wasn't sure Kacchan had entirely comprehended that, to Izuku, he was a picture of victory much closer to him than All Might had been. He was a hero Izuku knew, a hero Izuku could touch and talk to.

And his mom hadn't been wrong. After finding out he was quirkless, Izuku projected all his expectations of heroism onto Kacchan.

Izuku knew where people were coming from when they compared Kacchan to a villain, or said he acted like one. Kacchan's temperament wasn't the best, and he was way more aggressive than the average pro. Still… There was no denying that, as All Might himself had said, Kacchan had everything he needed to become an amazing hero in the future. He had the quirk, the technique, the will, the determination… While people who didn't know him thought he was better off as a villain, Izuku knew it in his heart that Kacchan could be nothing else if not a hero.

Izuku realized that the bedroom lights were out. Kacchan was apparently having a hard time with the bright light from the laptop screen, if he was wearing his glasses. He could have turned the bedroom light on. If he really didn't care about Izuku, if he really only cared about his own well-being, he might as well have done that.

And yes, Kacchan would probably argue that he didn't turn the light on because he needed Izuku to be well-rested and sleep well so that he didn't feel tired, but… The tiny spark of hope that Kacchan actually cared about him, even if just a little, had already blossomed inside Izuku's chest, and it would be hard to put down. Kacchan didn't have to hug him in the train. He didn't even have to take Izuku all the way to his apartment – he could have just asked someone for Inko's number and called her from the comfort of his bedroom. Izuku would have probably found a way to talk and interact to her more like this, even if he thought seeing her was more comforting than using Kacchan as his personal messenger.

Either way, Kacchan was not just trying to make Izuku happy. He was trying to make Izuku *very* happy.

Did Kacchan think he would also feel happier this way? Or was this out of his inherent need to be the best at everything he did?

Was this a proof that he actually cared about Izuku's well-being, and not only his own, as he constantly claimed? Or was it too much of a stretch?

“The fuck are you staring at?”, Kacchan broke him away from his thoughts, still not looking at him. Izuku blinked his eyes blankly, feeling like he had been caught red handed. He blushed, once again thankful for the darkness in the room.

What could he possibly answer? He didn’t know why he had been staring at Kacchan for so long, drinking in every detail he could. Did he fear their relationship would actually return to cold glares and sheer rivalry after he returned to his body, and thus was taking every opportunity he could to get closer to Kacchan or, at least, remember details about him? Or was there something else to it?

“Don’t pretend you weren’t staring, nerd, I can feel your damn eyes all over me like a creep”, Katsuki scoffed when Izuku didn’t say anything.

He needed to change subjects. At *once*. It would be weird to explain his reasons to Kacchan, and if he didn’t say anything, he would just become more suspicious. Ahh! Why was Izuku always so awkward?! He wished he didn’t get distracted and lost in thought so often.

“I – I was w-wondering”, he started, embarrassed. “If you – uh – could, could take a look at my back”, he swallowed dry. *Nailed it!*, he thought to himself.

“Eh?”, Katsuki frowned, making a tiny crease appear between his brows but still not looking at Izuku. *Why doesn’t he want to look at me?*

“You – you – you said there was a s-scar”, Izuku explained, nervously shoving his curls behind his ears several times (since they continued to fall down his face as soon as he placed them back). “On my back. You – t-thought it was from the villain attack? Maybe it can help us figure something out about the villain’s quirk”, he suggested.

Kacchan was silent for a while, his eyes staring at the laptop screen. Somehow, Izuku knew he wasn’t reading it, but rather thinking about his request.

“Tch”, was all Katsuki said before putting his pencil down and standing up from the chair. He turned the light in the room on without warning (making Izuku squint his eyes at the sudden change of brightness) before making his way over to the bed. Izuku’s heart began to race, for some reason.

Katsuki stopped in front of Izuku, staring down at him with his arms crossed above his chest. Izuku, who was still sitting crossed-legged on the middle of the bed, stared up at Katsuki with expectation in his eyes. Katsuki still wasn’t looking at him, his head tilted slightly to the side and bearing a glare on his face.

“Take your shirt off”, he instructed simply, in a tone that left no place for a discussion. Izuku’s heart rate doubled, but he did as Kacchan said. He turned on the bed so that his back would be turned to Katsuki and removed his shirt, feeling nervous.

Since his back was turned to Katsuki, he couldn’t see what he was doing. He decided it would be too awkward if he turned his head to look, so he stayed frozen in place, waiting. The hands holding his shirt were gripping the material so tightly that his knuckles had gone white.

Izuku heard some shuffling and then the mattress rattled, indicating Kacchan had sat down behind him in order to take a proper look. He swallowed dry in anticipation.

The tips of Kacchan's fingers touched his back – Izuku assumed he was touching the skin surrounding the scar – and goosebumps ran all over his body, making him suppress a shiver. For someone as feral as Kacchan, his fingers had a gentle touch – so gentle that Izuku never expected it from him. Amazing how the digits which could create destructive explosions could also feel so soft again the exposed skin of his back.

Then, Kacchan's fingers touched his scar directly and searing pain immediately burst through Izuku, breaking him away from his thoughts and making him black out.

Katsuki hissed as he jumped back several feet, clutching his throbbing hand close to his chest. At the same time, Deku screamed as if he was in terrible pain before his eyes rolled back into his head and he plopped down onto to the bed lifelessly, looking like a puppet whose strings had been cut. He simply lay there, face pale, eyes half-lidded and white, lips parted, face vacant of any expression, limbs askew beside him…

And, to Katsuki's horror, he remembered.

He remembered *everything*.

"Deku", a voice, far away, an echo. "Deku, holy fuck, wake up…"

Someone shaking him. It didn't hurt as much as he thought it would. He frowned.

"*Deku*. Don't you fucking dare, just wake the hell up, you fucker –"

Someone tapped his cheek, trying to urge him into awareness.

"*Deku!*"

He didn't remember ever hearing so much desperation in that too-familiar voice.

He parted his eyelids slowly, in confusion.

Katsuki's eyes were wide, his brows stuck in a worried expression that immediately dissipated as soon as Izuku's eyes focused on him. He let go of Izuku then, making the boy plop down on the bed in confusion and dizziness. What had happened?

"You goddamn son of a bitch", Katsuki said, something akin to betrayal in his voice. He sounded out of breath, as if he had just run a marathon, his voice high pitched and constricted. "Don't fucking *do* that again, what the fuck were you thinking? You piece of fucking *shit*!"

"Wha'…?", Izuku slurred, frowning and looking around in confusion. He tried to blink past the dizziness for a few moments and make sense of his surroundings before sitting up on the bed. His tongue felt like cotton and his brain felt like mashed potato. "Wha' happ'nd?", he asked, squinting up at Katsuki and having trouble focusing on his face.

"You fucking passed out", Katsuki breathed out, looking like he was struggling to regain his composure. He ran a shaky hand across his face in a failed attempt to calm down. Izuku continued to stare up at him in confusion, especially because there was accusation in Katsuki's tone, as if he thought Izuku had passed out on purpose just to piss him off.

"Wha'…?", he asked again, feeling like his brain was still in the process of rebooting.

"I touched your fucking scar and you *fucking passed out*", Katsuki pointed at him. Izuku noticed his hand was trembling a bit, but decided not to comment on it. He couldn't remember ever seeing Kacchan so distraught before in his life. His frown deepened.

"Kacchan", he asked, concern evident in his tone. "Are you 'kay?"

"Why the *fuck* are you asking me that for?", Katsuki scoffed, angry, but also sounding – and looking – frantic. "You're the one who was fucking unconscious for five minutes!"

"Five…?", Izuku asked pensively. Why did he pass out in the first place? He remembered asking Kacchan to check his back, but nothing after he removed his shirt. Had the touching caused him to pass out? If so, then why?

And why was Kacchan so nervous in the first place?

"Kacchan", Izuku called, swallowing dry and feeling more awake than a few moments before. He assessed Kacchan with sharp attention – shaking hands, panting, a glare that was a mixture of angry and nervous. He looked like he was about to either fight or fly. Izuku threw his legs off the bed and stood up, approaching the boy with an outstretched, reassuring hand. "I – I think you should sit down. You – you look like you're about to –"

"Don't *fucking* tell me what to do", Katsuki spat with pure rage, slapping Izuku's hand away from him and panting heavily. He was clutching one of his hands close to his chest. "Stay the fuck away from me", he added in a guttural voice, lowering his head and bending over, as if he was having more trouble breathing with each passing second.

“Kacchan –“

“Stay the *fuck* away from me, Deku!”, he repeated with a wheeze, trying to catch his breath. His eyes were still wide, as if he had seen a ghost, but he quickly squeezed them shut. Izuku couldn’t tell if he had done that because he was in pain or because he wanted to concentrate on calming down.

“What happened? I don’t understand”, Izuku admitted, standing at a safe distance from Kacchan but still holding out his hands in front of him, as if ready to catch the boy should he lose his footing. “You look nervous, Kacchan, please, just sit down –“

“*Shut the fuck up*”, Katsuki shook his head, his voice a mixture of a guttural growl and a gasp.

“You look about to fall over, Kacchan…”

“Shut the *fuck* up…”

“Kacchan, please, I’m worried…!”

“*Shut the fuck up*…”

“Kacchan, you have to breathe…!”

“Shut the fuck up…!”

Kacchan, watch out!

“Kacchan…”

Kacchan!

“Oh my god, Kacchan…!”

Kacchan!

Matte yo, Kacchan!

Kacchan!

“Shut the ***fuck*** up!!!”

“Agh!”

Katsuki panted heavily, finally raising his head and focusing on the here and now. Deku was fallen on the floor, his brow crunched in hurt and betrayal, his eyes wide and teary, and a hand clutching his nose. Katsuki could see the blood seeping from his nostril and in between his fingers.

He found his own hands clutched into fists, one of his knuckles throbbing. His teeth were gritted and his heart was racing.

Had he – had he punched Deku?

His head was spinning and he couldn't breathe. Too many thoughts. Too many memories. His own nose was aching painfully from the way he had decked Deku, mimicking the boy's pain.

He hadn't meant to. He really hadn't meant to this time.

Fuck. Never in his life did he think he would actually feel sorry for punching Deku.

Deku was still staring him as a scared animal, a hurt animal. He wasn't moving.

Katsuki stared back at him with horrified eyes, and he panted and panted and panted.

After everything, he'd punched Deku.

Why did he? He couldn't… He hadn't meant to. He really hadn't.

"Kacchan…", Deku tried to say, voice constricted by pain and muffled by the hand holding his bleeding nose.

"I – fuck, I didn't – I didn't mean –", Katsuki panted, his chest heaving more and more with each passing second. All he could remember was his first fight against Deku, back at that ridiculous training practice, when Deku defeated him and made him look like a fool in front of everyone. He had hyperventilated so hard back then, and it took All Might to calm him down, because Deku was strong, Deku had a quirk, Deku could defeat him, Deku could crush him into a million little pieces –

And Deku had jumped in front of a villain attack to save Katsuki, Deku had given his life for his without thinking about it, after everything Katsuki did to him, after everything Katsuki said to him, *quirkless loser, useless, quirkless, Deku, why don't you take a swan dive off the roof of the building…*

There was no All Might to calm him down this time.

He could remember everything.

And Deku – he had just passed out, he had screamed and passed out because Katsuki touched him, because of Katsuki, and he had looked dead, as dead as he had been back in that alley, because Katsuki remembered, he remembered it now, he remembered what had happened to Deku because of him, he remembered his own rage and anger and guilt and sheer desperation for seeing Deku's body looking all askew and lifeless, and those big fucking green eyes staring at him with nothing in them, nothing in them, nothing in them –

Deku was still staring at him, eyes big and wide and teary, but he was hurt, he was confused and betrayed, because Katsuki had punched him, Katsuki had fucking hurt him again, and why did he care anyway, this was just stupid fucking Deku, Katsuki didn't care about him, shouldn't care about him, couldn't care about him, he was above it, he had to be, he had to be the best, he couldn't care for Deku, his enemy, his rival, his – his –

He dry heaved. He couldn't breathe. He couldn't think. He had to calm down.

“Kacchan!”

He had to breathe. He had to breathe. He was looking like a loser. He was looking weak and pathetic and he couldn’t look like that, especially not in front of Deku. Not fucking Deku. *Not fucking Deku*.

Katsuki turned on his heels and rushed to the bathroom, slamming the door behind him so loudly that the entire dorm probably heard it. Izuku was immediately rushing to his feet, chasing Katsuki and ignoring the blood on his nose and his hands.

“Kacchan! Are you ok? *Kacchan*!”

Katsuki looked at himself in the mirror. What a fucking mess.

He rushed to the toilet and vomited, coughing and choking and spitting and feeling disgusted. He leaned on the toiled and panted, trying to catch his breath. He needed to calm down. He needed to think rationally.

So ok. Touching Deku’s scar caused Deku enough pain to pass out and made Katsuki remember everything that had happened and that he had forgotten. He remembered the fight, the way Deku shoved him away and took the blow in his place, and waking up to find Deku dead. He remembered freaking out really hard over a dead Deku. He remembered *fucking losing his shit,* like Kirishima said he had. Like he had refused to believe.

He didn’t know why. He didn’t even like Deku. Was it out of guilt, for having gotten him killed? Was it out of anger, for being saved by Deku, of all people?

Was it out of something else?

He lost his breath again. Ok. Ok. Too many feelings to think about. Too many feelings to compute. Better leave it for later.

He got to his feet and ran the sink, rinsing his mouth and then washing his face. He needed to breathe, organize his thoughts, and calm down. No use freaking out over shitty Deku.

Fuck, but Katsuki had *punched* him.

He hadn’t meant to. He probably did it out of instinct, he had been freaking out so hard. It had been a fucking accident.

What kind of hero would he be if he lost all control when a person who he didn’t even like died because of him? If he punched people because he panicked? If he couldn’t get a grip of himself?

Fine, ok. Breathe in, breathe out. He washed his face again, trying to cool his head. In, out. In, out. In, out. He gripped the sink hard and looked at himself in the mirror as he breathed. In, out, in, out, in, out.

How fucking ridiculous.

Katsuki didn't know how long he was in the bathroom for, but he assumed it was a long time. He did his best to keep his head clear and functioning as he turned the sink off and straightened his back, still controlling his breathing. Running the back of his hand beneath his nose and sniffing, he swallowed dry and decided he had regained his composure enough to step out.

He opened the door and the first thing he saw was the stupid nerd, snapping his head as soon as he heard Katsuki, looking up at him with those big fucking eyes of his. He looked more worried than Katsuki had ever seen him, dry blood coated on his nose and upper lip, running down his chin.

Fuck.

Katsuki's heart gave a twinge of pain and guilt. Izuku probably felt that, too, and Katsuki found himself embarrassed about it.

"Kacchan", Izuku said, getting to his feet from where he had been sitting patiently beside the bathroom door. "Are you ok? Are you feeling better?"

Katsuki stared at him, crimson locked on green. God. Why was Deku like this? Why was he *fucking* like this?

"Your mom was right about you", Katsuki said, mustering all his self-control to sound as neutral as possible as he walked past Deku. "You really are a fucking loser".

"Uh, my mom never said that", Izuku frowned.

"Yeah, but she asked me to take care of you because you have no self-preservation skills whatso fucking ever, and she was right about *that*", he explained, his back turned to Deku as he sat back down on his rolling chair and ran his fingers through his hair. "Hence, you're a loser".

"Kacchan –", Izuku tried again, approaching Katsuki and outstretching a hand towards him again.

"I fucking *punched* you, Deku", he said through gritted teeth, head bowed and hands clenched into fists. "And don't tell me it doesn't fucking hurt or whatever bullshit you're about to shove at me to make me feel better, because my nose is throbbing and stinging as fuck", he scoffed. Izuku lowered his hand and stared at Katsuki's back.

"Yes", he nodded, looking serious. "But I know you didn't mean it. I can feel your guilt it, too", he explained. Katsuki didn't want to admit it to himself, but he felt relieved at these words. At least he wouldn't have to apologize for punching Deku, since the nerd knew it had been an accident. "And I could also feel how distraught you were", Izuku added. "Can you please tell me what happened?"

Katsuki was silent. He didn't want to talk about it. He didn't want to open up.

“From what I got, you touched my scar and – and for some reason, I blacked out –“, Izuku started, clearly nervous and trying his best to keep up with what was happening.

“Yeah, you screamed. It probably hurt you”, Katsuki interrupted him. After a few silent moments, he added: “It hurt my hand, too”.

“O-Okay”, Izuku nodded with determination. “So I think it’s safe for us to assume that the scar is definitely connected to the villain’s quirk”.

“Yeah”, Katsuki huffed, his back still turned to Izuku.

“But I don’t think hurting your hand is enough to make you that upset, Kacchan”, Izuku added hesitantly when it became clear Katsuki wouldn’t say anything else. Katsuki sighed. “You hurt your hands all the time when using your quirk. So can you please tell me what else happened?”

Katsuki gritted his teeth. Stupid fucking nosy Deku.

“I’m not fucking *upset*”, he growled, hiding his embarrassment behind anger as usual. He turned on the chair to glare at Deku, hoping the look in his eyes would be enough to make the shitty nerd drop the subject. “Just fucking leave it”.

Izuku looked at him like he wanted to protest, but something changed in his expression and he allowed his shoulders to slump in defeat. He threw himself down on the bed and sat directly in front of Katsuki, looking like he wanted to argue.

Kacchan had complained about Izuku not dropping subjects that made him uncomfortable, and Izuku was pretty sure that Kacchan was uncomfortable in that moment. So… perhaps it would be better to talk about that later. Even if curiosity was driving him crazy. If Kacchan could try to be better, then Izuku could too, right?

“How’s your back?”, Katsuki asked before Izuku could change his mind and keep asking him questions. “Does it hurt?”

“No”, Izuku shook his head, looking up at Katsuki. “It – I don’t even remember it hurting, to be honest. Do you have any idea why this happened?”

“No”, Katsuki admitted grumpily, even though he hated admitting not knowing something.

“I think we should talk to someone about this”, Izuku said. “Aizawa sensei, or – or All Might. Will this happen every time you touch the scar? Does it have to be an intentional touch? What if you accidentally bump on my back and –“

“Ok, just because I accidentally punched you, it doesn’t give you a free pass to go back to your fucking mumbling sessions. Zip it”, Katsuki interrupted him with an angry look. Izuku’s mouth hung open for a few seconds before he snapped it closed and looked away from Kacchan.

“Uh…”, he said awkwardly after a few moments of silence. “What about your hand?”

“What about my hand?”, Katsuki asked tiredly.

“You said it hurt. When you touched the scar. Does it still hurt?”

Katsuki scoffed.

“No”.

“Oh. Good”.

An awkward silence fell between them.

“So… What did it look like?”, Izuku asked.

“Hm?”

“The scar. I can’t see it”.

“It looks… big”, Katsuki shrugged. “Like someone sliced your back with a big ass sword or something. It looks fresh, too”.

“Huh”, Izuku nodded. “Weird”.

“Yeah, let me tell you about fucking *weird*”.

“Do you think it’s in my body, too?”

“*What*?”

“The scar. I mean, if it’s in my soul… It’s probably in my body, too”.

“I don’t fucking know”.

“Do you think we should ask Recovery Girl about it?”

“What difference will it make?”

“I’m sorry?”

“What’s the fucking difference if the scar is in your body or not? It won’t change anything”.

“Well… Yeah… But don’t you want to know?”

“No”.

“Why not?”

“Just because, shitty Deku”.

“I don’t understand”.

“Get in fucking line”.

Awkward silence.

“Kacchan…”

“Look”, Katsuki sighed tiredly, rubbing his palm on his face before continuing. “If you couldn’t fucking tell by now, I’m not in the mood for conversation”. With that, he turned back towards his laptop and went back to what he had been doing before.

Izuku lowered his head and swallowed dry, looking determined.

“I don’t think you should, uh…”

“*What*, Deku?”

“It’s just… You look tired. Maybe you should rest a bit?”

“I basically just woke up”.

“But –“

“I have stuff to do”.

More silence.

Izuku was at a loss for words. Nothing had gone as he had planned. If anything, things were even more complicated, now.

Why was everything so complicated with Kacchan?

He sighed, taking a hand to his nose. It felt broken and it was still throbbing. He ended up letting out a hiss as his fingers contacted with his puffy skin.

Weird. When he was literally dragged on the floor by a train, his back received no tangible damage. Why was he bleeding and hurting after Kacchan punched him? Why wasn’t the skin of his back all scraped and bruised, but his nose was bleeding because of Kacchan’s fist?

Was it because it was Kacchan?

“Stop poking it, loser”, Katsuki had tilted his head towards him, watching him with sharp attention.

“Uh, sorry”, Izuku retrieved his hand from his nose, embarrassed. “I didn’t mean to hurt you”.

“It’s not *that*”, Katsuki squinted his eyes at Izuku before pointing him with a disbelieving scowl and shaking his head in disapproval. “Fuck, you’ll really put everyone else before your own well-being like a fucking moron, won’t you?”, he scoffed. Somehow, the reprimand was

different than Kacchan's previous one. It sounded a bit more… caring? No, that wasn't it. It sounded almost guilty.

Izuku didn't understand.

"It's – it's just – I thought –", he tried to justify. Katsuki stood up from his rolling chair and sat on the edge of the bed beside Izuku.

"Yeah, I know what you thought. Just shut up", he instructed sharply. Taking his fingers to Izuku's chin, he lifted the boy's head up to take a look at the nose. "It's broken", he announced after a quick inspection.

"Yeah, I know that", Izuku sighed, feeling embarrassed by the proximity and close contact to Kacchan. The fingers tilting Izuku's chin up were incredibly gentle for such an aggressive person.

"Stop acting so fucking smart about it", Katsuki huffed in annoyance, still inspecting the nose.

"I wasn't!", Izuku protested. "It's just – you have a mean swing. There's no way it *wouldn't* be broken", he explained with a shrug. A quick, barely noticeable, look of intense guilt flashed through Kacchan's crimson eyes, and Izuku finally realized what his words must have sounded like to the boy. "S-Sorry!", he quickly added. "That wasn't what I meant! It's – it's just – I mean –"

"Just stop", Katsuki cut him off sharply, letting go of his chin. Before Izuku could say anything else, Katsuki pinched the bridge of his nose between two strong fingers. Izuku yelped in pain and surprise, pulling back from the touch.

"Ouch! What was that for?!", he protested, protecting his broken nose behind two hands and looking offended. Why would Kacchan deliberately hurt him like that?!

"I'm setting it back into place. Or do you want your nose to be crooked for the rest of your shitty life?", Katsuki responded in a deadpan, as if that was obvious. Izuku frowned.

"You can't just grab my nose like that! I wasn't prepared!", he continued, still shrinking away from Katsuki's hand. Katsuki rolled his eyes.

"Look, shitty Deku, I don't have all day. Just stop whining and let me do this", he said impatiently.

"No!", Izuku protested again, leaning away from Katsuki's hands even further. "Do you even know how to reset a nose?"

"Of course I fucking do", Katsuki huffed out of his nose, getting more annoyed with each passing second. He'd been managing to keep his cool until now, probably out of the guilt for what he had done to Deku and the memories that had flooded his head, but he was way too short-fused to keep up the gentle act for very long. "Stop squirming. It will be over in a second".

“No!”, Izuku exclaimed, swatting Katsuki’s hand away.

“So you break your damn arms all the fucking time without saying a word about it, but as soon as I try to reset your damn nose you get all whiny?”, Katsuki scowled at him. “How the fuck does that make sense?”

“I never broke my nose before!”, Izuku justified, involuntary tears from the broken nose pooling in his eyes.

“That’s actually surprising”, Katsuki nodded, impressed. However, he didn’t waste time in sliding closer to Deku and trying to remove the boy’s hand from his own face.

“No! Kacchan, stop!”, Izuku yelped, struggling against Katsuki’s hands.

“*You* stop, damn nerd”, Katsuki growled, successfully pulling one of Deku’s hands away from his face and pinning it to the top of the bed, only to have him replace it with his other hand. Katsuki snarled. “Just let me do this already! I can’t hold you down and reset your nose at the same time!”

“Then don’t! I don’t want you to!”, he cried.

“You’d rather have a crooked nose, idiot? *Stop! Struggling!”*

“Noooooo! Get off!”

“I’m trying to do you a favor, you fucking moron!”

“How do you know if my nose will even be crooked? Do you think your punch affected my physical body?”

“This is not – stop *squirming*, god damn it – This is *not* the time to discuss your fucking theories, Deku”.

“I want to know before you do this! Let’s go to the infirmary so that I can check my body ooooOOOOOOOUCH!”

Crack! Katsuki leaned back on the bed, triumphant. He had managed to set Deku’s nose back, despite of the boy’s struggling. Deku sat with both hands clutching his throbbing nose, turning on the bed so that he would be lying in a fetal position, eyes squeezed shut and a grimace on his face. Katsuki smirked at him before standing up.

“There. Consider this my apology for punching you”, he said victoriously. Deku parted his eyelids slightly in order to point Katsuki with an indignant glare.

“You just hurt me even more!”, he protested. “How is *that* an apology?”

“It hurt for a second, you whiny baby. If you’d left it as it was, it would have hurt for a lot longer”, he explained, sitting back down on the rolling chair and resuming his reading on the laptop. “Plus, I could feel your pain, too, so we’re even”.

“No, we’re not!”, Izuku cried, adjusting himself on the bed and still clutching his nose with one hand.

“Yes, we are. Now shut the fuck up, I’m trying to read”.

“How do you even know how to reset a nose?!”

“I’ve broken mine enough times to learn it”.

“What? Really?”

“*Yes*, Deku. Can you shut your trap now?”

“But how?”

“How do you think, dumbass? *Training*”.

“Huh. That’s weird. I never broke my nose while training”.

“That’s because you never trained as hard as I did”.

A pause.

“You really think so?”

“I *know* so. While you were busy being a pathetic wimp I was working hard to get where I wanted”.

Izuku blinked several times over. In a way, Kacchan was right. He only ever started working out and training hard after he met All Might… Whereas Katsuki had probably been training his whole life in order to get in shape and be able to control his quirk.

Kacchan’s amazingness wasn’t a natural trait. It was due to his own effort and determination.

Izuku understood better why he admired the boy so much. He also found that he could understand better why Kacchan seemed to resent him. Despite his arrogance and horrible personality, it was undeniable that he had trained hard his whole life in order to get into UA, while Izuku… Izuku went from nothing to being his rival in less than a year. Despite all their differences, despite all the years Izuku struggled and dreamed to become a hero, despite Izuku’s own pain – he thought he could understand a bit of Kacchan’s anger, now.

Kacchan had always put a special effort to be the best. Izuku – Izuku didn’t have a quirk, so he never trained. There was no reason for him to. It probably pissed Kacchan off to see someone he deemed effortless get at the same stage as he was without having to go through the training and preparation that he did.

But again, Kacchan didn’t know what it was like to be quirkless. He didn’t know how hard Izuku worked to be where he was. He didn’t know about the intensive training with All Might, and he thought Izuku’s notebooks were just a pathetic waste of time, when in fact was one of the things that made him have a whole new perspective on quirk theory and practice.

Kacchan may have trained hard, but that didn't mean Izuku didn't do that, too. They just trained in different ways, at different paces.

"I worked hard, too, you know", Izuku said, defensive. Katsuki stopped scrolling and turned to look at him, something weird in his eyes. "You know Takoba?"

"The beach park?", Katsuki asked. Izuku nodded.

"Yes. It was filled with trash that came from the sea and that people threw there once it became too polluted", he explained.

"Yeah. The place became shit in just a few years", Katsuki scoffed, eyeing Izuku with suspicion.

"I cleaned it up", he said. Katsuki frowned.

"What?", he asked after a few seconds.

"I cleaned it up. It was part of All Might's training to pass One For All to me", he explained.

"You cleaned up that entire beach?", Katsuki scoffed in disbelief, a small mocking smirk appearing on his lips.

"Yes", Izuku nodded, unfaltering. He felt like Kacchan needed to know that. He needed to *understand*. "I spent the entire time before the UA entrance exam doing that. And training. Every day. Every free time I had, I – I trained. Night and day. So that I could be worthy of inheriting All Might's power. So that I could be worthy of getting where I am. So that I could be worthy of being at the same place as you".

Katsuki continued to stare at him.

"I – I may not have trained for as long as you did", Izuku continued, serious. "Or as hard as you did. And – I may have been born quirkless. But I didn't get where I am without effort. A – A lot of people helped me, that's true, and without them… I wouldn't be where I am", he admitted. "But I worked hard. And I tried hard. Maybe not as hard as you did, but – but I still tried my best".

Katsuki simply stared.

"I felt like you should know that", Izuku concluded, feeling awkward. Katsuki said nothing for a long time.

"You should clean your nose up", was what he finally responded after what felt like an eternity. "There's still blood in it".

Without another word, he turned back towards his computer and went back to reading.

Izuku sighed. To be fair, he wasn't really expecting a proper response from Kacchan.

But there was something in his crimson eyes. Something that told Izuku that he was thinking about what he had said. Perhaps he was reconsidering his biases?

Izuku could only hope so.

He stood up from the bed, meaning to head to the bathroom, until he remembered he wouldn't be able to run the sink on his own, or even touch the water in the first place. He looked at Kacchan hesitantly.

"Uh… I – I don't know how I can clean myself up", he admitted. Kacchan sighed, impatient.

"Just use your shirt or whatever".

"What?! No! It will be all bloodied!"

"So what? That's not even your real fucking shirt, just a soul version or whatever".

"Still, I'll have to walk around with blood on my shirt all the time until we figure out how to put me back into my body!"

"So *what*? No one can see you, anyway".

"You can!"

"I'm not bothered by it".

"But I am!"

"Well, then what the fuck do you want me to do? Clean you up?"

Upon Izuku's silence, Katsuki turned on the rolling chair to glare at him.

"No *fucking* way".

"Kacchan, please! I don't want to go around looking all bloodied!"

"I don't give a shit. I'm not doing it".

"Come on! You were the one who punched me! *And* the one who told me to clean up!"

"I didn't fucking mean to punch you, asshole! I told you that!"

"I know, but still!"

"No. Not happening".

"Please!"

"*No*".

"All you have to do is rub some water on my face! I can't do it myself!"

“Not my problem”.

“Come on, Kacchan!”

“Shut the *fuck* up”.

“Please!”

“Stop it already. I’ll punch you again”.

“It’s not my fault you made me bleed!”

“Fuck, you’re so fucking *annoying*”, Katsuki stood up from his seat abruptly, grabbing Izuku’s wrist and dragging him aggressively towards the bathroom, using more force than necessary. Izuku yelped in surprise, but didn’t resist.

Katsuki ran the sink and grabbed Izuku by the hair on the nape of his neck, making the boy shiver as he pulled on the curls. Katsuki shoved his head closer to the sink unceremoniously, as if he wanted to get that over with as soon as possible, and pooled water on his free hand.

He splashed the water on Izuku’s face, rubbing it until the blood was cleared out. Once Izuku’s face was clean, Katsuki turned the water off and let go of him more roughly than necessary. Izuku found himself staring up at Katsuki with blown pupils and parted lips, eyes wide. His face was dripping wet.

“*What*?”, Katsuki asked, grumpy. “You wanted me to clean your shitty face up, right? There, it’s clean. Will you let me study now or do you have any more fucking requests?”, he added sarcastically. Izuku simply stared at him.

He was feeling weird. Why was his heart racing so much?

And why did he want Kacchan’s fingers on his hair again?

Despite of the roughness… it had felt really nice.

Izuku thought back to the day he had woken up to find Kacchan’s fingers tangled in his hair while he slept. Did Kacchan enjoy playing with his curls as much as Izuku liked having them played with?

Why on *earth* was he thinking about that anyway?!?

“*What is it*?”, Katsuki insisted when Izuku continued to stare at him with something akin to surprise in his face. “Quit with that fucking look”.

Izuku simply continued to stare. He noticed Kacchan had removed his glasses at some point, but he couldn’t remember when. He found himself surprised that he wanted Kacchan to put them back.

“Weirdo”, Katsuki commented upon his silence, giving Izuku one final scoff before turning on his heels and leaving the bathroom. Izuku stayed there, glued to his feet and trying to

make sense of his emotions.

Something weird was going on in his chest.

He only hoped Kacchan wasn't feeling it too.

"Can you tell me where we're going?"

"No".

"Why not?"

"God, are you fucking five? Just shut up and follow".

"But I want to know! You're being all mysterious about it!"

"You'll know when it's time".

"Why do you *always* say that?"

"Because I always tell you to shut your trap and you never listen".

"Ugh, fine, Kacchan".

Silence. A few people walking by them on the hall were giving Katsuki weird looks, but he was past caring about that. These bunch of extras most likely already knew that he had a stupid ghost attached to him; then why give him those judge-y looks? Fucking losers.

"Why do you have scissors on you anyway?", Izuku asked after less them a minute, making Katsuki point him with a victorious glare.

"You just can't help yourself, can you", he scoffed.

"It's not my fault if you never tell me anything and I have to keep asking about stuff!"

"Just admit you're nosy".

"It's not nosy to want to know why you are carrying scissors in school grounds!"

"I'm not going to kill anyone, if that's what you're so fucking worried about".

“I *know* that; if you were to kill someone, you wouldn’t need scissors”.

“I’ll take that as a compliment”.

“It kind of is, but – but that’s not the point. You still haven’t told me what the scissors are for, and – wait. Isn’t this the way to Recovery Girl’s medical bay?”

“Take a fucking guess”.

“What are you going to do with those scissors?!”

“What do you think, nerd? Use your brain for once”.

Hesitant silence.

“Kacchan, I appreciate it, but – but I – I don’t really –“

“*Stop* fucking stuttering and just spit it out, loser. I fucking hate when you go all trippy over your words because you don’t have the balls to speak your mind”.

Izuku glared at him.

“You’re being an asshole”.

“I’ve already told you that you only need to tell me that when I *don’t know* I’m being one”.

“Then stop being one on purpose!”

“Don’t fucking tell me what to do!”

“Fine, then I’ll just let you know that I don’t want you to cut my hair!”

“*Ehh*?! Why the fuck not?”

“Because I’m going to look ugly!”

“Joke’s on you, shitty Deku, you’re *already* ugly”.

“Hey!”

“What, you don’t think I have the skills to cut your fucking hair? Is that it?”

“Well, yes!”

“Now you’re just asking me to put another use to my damn scissors”.

“I just mean I’ve never seen you cut anyone’s hair! How do I know you won’t mess mine up?”

“There’s no way it’ll be *more* messed up than it already is, loser; you can barely see with those bangs in your eyes”.

“Just ask someone else to do it, then!”

“Like hell I will. I can do it myself”.

“But I don’t want you to!”

“Do I look like I give a shit?”

“I do! It’s my hair!”

“Well, too bad for you”.

“Why do you even care about my hair so much?!”

Izuku hadn’t meant to ask that, but in the heat of their discussion, his brain-to-mouth filter was compromised. They both stopped in his tracks.

His eyes widened in embarrassment and he stared at Kacchan with apprehension and anticipation, expecting an explosive reaction. Instead, Kacchan became very silent, pointedly avoiding Izuku’s face and glaring at his opposite direction.

“I was just trying to do you a favor, you dumbass”, Katsuki scoffed, sounding angry and… something else that Izuku couldn’t quite name. “But I guess it’s my own fault for trying to please an ungrateful asshole like you”.

Katsuki turned on his heels in order to walk back the way they’d come from, but Izuku instinctively reached out for him and grabbed his wrist, making him stop in his tracks. Katsuki didn’t look at him, but didn’t shrug away from the touch, either.

Could it be? Had this actually been Kacchan’s attempt to… do something nice for Izuku? With no personal interest? For the first time ever?

A deep sense of guilt invaded Izuku’s chest at this. Maybe Kacchan just didn’t know how to be nice, and this was his (failed) attempt at being so? Maybe he just *had* to be assertive about everything in his life? If Izuku was being honest, he had sincerely thought that Kacchan was going to give him a horrible haircut just so that he could make fun of him afterwards, but maybe… Just maybe, Kacchan had actually been honest about his endeavor. And if that was truly the case – Izuku wanted, with his whole heart, to believe it was –, then he owed Kacchan an apology for being so dismissive and rude to his offer, even though it wasn’t his own fault it had been so badly delivered.

“Kacchan”, he started, hoping the boy would be able to make out the sincerity in his tone. “I’m – I’m sorry”, he lowered his head in shame, never letting go of Katsuki’s wrist. “I thought – well. I didn’t think you were serious. I thought you were trying to make fun of me”.

Katsuki was silent for a while.

“Tch. Whatever”, he scoffed before shrugging away from Izuku’s touch, resuming his walk to the opposite direction from the medical bay.

“No, Kacchan, wait!”, Izuku called after him. God, he had screwed up, hadn’t he? Kacchan’s first attempt of being nice and he… dismissed him as if it was nothing. Knowing the boy, Izuku was sure that he would be too proud and stubborn to ever try being nice to him again, if he didn’t fix this now. “Wait!”

Matte yo, Kacchan!

“*What*?”, Katsuki stopped on his tracks and turned on his heels so abruptly that Izuku collided with his chest. He lost balance and would have fallen on his ass if Katsuki hadn’t reached out a hand and grabbed him by the front of his shirt, giving him the support necessary to regain his footing. Once Izuku was standing on his feet again, Katsuki promptly shoved his hands into his pockets and glared at the boy in front of him.

“I’m sorry”, Izuku said again, a serious look on his face. “I didn’t mean to dismiss you like that”.

“Just fucking forget about it”, Katsuki scowled, ready to turn on his heels again. Izuku could feel the anger coming from Kacchan and invading himself, making him feel annoyed and short-fused. *Damn*. After everything that had happened, Izuku completely forgot to tell Kacchan about his theory – about them needing to balance and control their emotions in order to be happy.

It was a bit too late, now. He would have to remember about that later, because on that moment, he could feel Kacchan’s anger invading him and making his brain-to-mouth filter become even *less* existent.

“Look, it’s not my fault I thought that, ok?!”, Izuku called out after him, his hands tightening into fists. “You’re the one who’s never lost an opportunity to make me feel bad about myself!”

Katsuki stopped walking again and slowly turned his head to look at Izuku, anger and disbelief etched in his crimson eyes. Izuku continued to glare at him, internally telling himself to *calm down, take a breath, don’t let his anger contaminate you, don’t say something you’ll regret later, be mindful of Kacchan’s feelings*. At the same time, however, a small voice inside his head was overruling his best attempts at being considerate by constantly screaming *DIE DIE DIE DIE* in a loop. Was this how Kacchan felt all the time? Was this why he had such a hard time controlling his sour temper?

Katsuki was still staring at Izuku, as if waiting for him to continue. If Izuku’s theory was right, then *he* was the one who ended up bearing all of Kacchan’s anger, and Kacchan himself was probably feeling it in a lower intensity. Still, rational thought and attempts to control himself left him as his mind was overcome with thoughts of resentment and self-righteousness.

“It’s only natural I thought you’d want to humiliate me, so stop being so stubborn about it just because I misunderstood your intentions!”, Izuku added angrily, despite of himself. God, Kacchan’s anger was *really* hard to control. He was probably scowling, or making an angry expression – either way, the muscles in his face hurt for doing something he was so unused to. “Just go back to the infirmary and cut my damn hair already! And next time you want to

do something nice for someone, don't be such an asshole about it! There was no way I could tell you wanted to do me a favor when you kept calling me names and telling me off like that!"

Katsuki stared at Izuku with a mixture of confusion, annoyance, and horror. Probably too overwhelmed by these feelings to continue feeling so angry, Izuku felt Kacchan's rage leave his body so fast that he became dizzy, as if his blood pressure had dropped suddenly. He panted and blinked his eyes several times in order to get rid of the black spots dancing in front of them, before looking up at Kacchan, who still had a very uncomfortable expression on his face.

"What the *fuck*?", was all Katsuki managed to say, his voice barely above a whisper and a confused scowl on his face.

"S-Sorry", Izuku said, bending over and leaning his hands on his knees. He was feeling very exhausted after such an emotional outburst. Kacchan's anger was a heavy weight to bear, even if just for a few minutes. "I ended up with all of your anger again".

"Yeah, I could fucking *tell* that", Katsuki said, still wearing that confused, horrified scowl on his face and staring at Izuku as if he had grown another head. "It was creepy as fuck".

"Well", Izuku took a deep breath, leaning on the wall beside him so that he could stand up straight and running the back of his free hand beneath his nose, which was still stinging. "That's what you look and sound like all the time".

"No, it's fucking not", Katsuki gave him a humorless chuckle.

"Yes, it *is*", Izuku protested, his tone leaving no place for an argument. Katsuki opted to argue anyway.

"No, it's not, because my face actually knows how to look angry", he pointed out, giving Izuku an almost impressed look. He looked very taken aback by everything that had happened in the course of the past two minutes. "You were just spitting rage at me while looking like you were about to cry".

"I wasn't looking like I was about to cry!", Izuku protested.

"Yes, you were".

"No, I wasn't!"

"I was the one who could see your stupid face, so shut the hell up. Just face it – you don't know how to look angry", Katsuki rolled his eyes, grabbing Izuku by his elbow – in a way that was nowhere near as aggressive as it could have been – and dragging him along the hall. They were headed back to Recovery Girl's medical bay, and Izuku felt a righteous sense of triumph overcome his tiredness. Was this all it took to successfully communicate with Kacchan? Yelling angry truths at him?

“Of *course* I know how to look angry!”, he protested, offended. He glared at Kacchan and scowled. “See? I’m doing it right now!”

Katsuki observed him for a few moments, studying his face.

“You look like you haven’t been able to take a shit in a week”, was his conclusion.

“*Kacchan*!”, Izuku protested. “That’s not true! I know how to look angry!”

“No, you don’t. You have too much of a baby face to do that”.

“I *don’t* have a baby face!”

“Yes, you do. It’s fucking ridiculous”.

“Stop saying that!”

“But it’s true, asshole. It sucks that my anger ends up inside someone who doesn’t know how to use it”.

“You don’t know how to use it either!”

“The *fuck* did you just say?”

“You always end up losing your patience for no reason and yelling at people all the time! Everyone knows you’re short-fused. You lose control of your anger really easily, so you don’t know how to use it, either!”

“I don’t fucking lose control of anything, dipshit. Everything I do is coldly calculated. And that’s rich coming from the guy who just lost his shit on me five minutes ago”.

“Because I was *mirroring your anger*! It wasn’t my fault!”

“Are you saying it was *my* fault, shitty Deku?”

“Yes! I was only angry because *you* were angry!”

“And I was only angry because you’re a piece of shit who will spend hours whining about me being mean to you or whatever and then tell me the fuck off the *moment* I try to do something nice!”

“I’ve already told you I didn’t know what you meant! I couldn’t tell you were trying to be nice!”

“That’s because you’re a fucking blockhead with no functional brains!”

“No, it’s because you’re always angry about everything, and telling me you will do something I asked you not to do *despite* what I want is not being nice! It’s being an asshole!”

Katsuki glared at him, but said nothing. Incredibly, he looked willing to listen to Izuku for once. Was this a rare instance of a situation where Katsuki had acted like an asshole without

it being on purpose? Was this Izuku's first actual chance to let Katsuki know he was being an asshole, like he had requested?

"I appreciate you wanting to cut my hair for me", Izuku continued, trying to be more patient. Kacchan clearly had a hard time understanding his point, and yelling at him was earning no results. "But you can't just tell me you will do something I don't want you to, *despite* me not wanting you to, and expect me to be thankful for it. I know you wanted to do something nice, but it doesn't matter if *you* think it's nice. I have to think it's nice, too!"

"You don't think me taking the fucking time to walk all the way over here just to cut your shitty hair is *nice*?", Katsuki asked, annoyed.

"I think it is, now that I know you were serious about it!", Izuku quickly explained. "But… Before, for example. You reset my nose without giving me the time to think about it, even though I was in pain! You can't just do something I don't want you to and call me ungrateful for not liking it!"

"I can do whatever the *fuck* I want", Katsuki growled angrily, but it sounded more out of the *need* to be right about everything than out of the belief that he was actually right.

"Kacchan", Izuku sighed. "I'm serious".

Katsuki pointedly avoided looking at him, looking grumpier than ever. Izuku took the silence – rather than a series of screamed curses – as an indication to continue.

"Look", Izuku tried again, forcing himself to be patient. He was glad he and Kacchan were talking for once, instead of going straight for throwing punches. "I couldn't tell you were actually willing to cut my hair, because you didn't sound like you were. You – you sounded like you wanted to make me look ugly, with a messed-up haircut. This is why I told you I didn't want you to do it! Not because I didn't want you to do me a favor, or because I thought I didn't need it, but because – because I thought you didn't mean it!"

Katsuki squinted his eyes, tilting his head so that he would be able to silently glare at Deku.

"You don't have to be so defensive all the time", Izuku added, offering Kacchan a tiny, tentative smile. "No one will judge you for being nice every now and then. People may comment on it because they'll notice the difference from your previous behavior, but – no one will judge you. *Or* mock you".

"I don't give a shit what anyone thinks about me", Katsuki responded simply. "If I did, I would be just as much of a loser as you are".

"Then would it hurt you to try and be nicer to people? If you don't care what they'll think of it?"

"What fucking difference does it make, if I don't give a shit what they think in the first place?"

“The difference is that they would be happier”, Izuku told him with seriousness. “And I have a strong feeling that *you* would be, too”.

Katsuki studied Izuku’s face for a long time.

Lost in green, expectant eyes.

He wanted so hard to have something to say. Some retort. Some way to win that argument.

He turned away, unable to face Izuku anymore.

“Tch. Whatever. Let’s get you that fucking haircut”.

“You can’t give him a haircut”.

“What?! After all that trouble?”, Izuku exclaimed.

“What the *FUCK*? Why the fuck not?”, Katsuki shouted.

“Watch your language, young man”, Recovery Girl reprimanded, poking hard at Katsuki’s foot with her cane. She was standing in front of Izuku’s room, blocking the way. “And you can’t compromise his physical integrity in any way. That is why”.

“How the fuck is giving – *ouch*!”, he hissed as Recovery Girl poked his foot again at the swear word. “How is giving him a haircut compromising his physical integrity?!”

“We still don’t know everything there is to know about the quirk that disconnected Midoriya from his soul”, Recovery Girl explained. “Because of this, I don’t want to make any drastic changes to his body or his appearance until he gets back into it. We don’t know how his soul could react to that”.

“That doesn’t make any f---freaking sense”, he corrected himself before he ended up swearing again. Recovery Girl squinted her eyes at him. “So you can poke needles and all that shit into him but I can’t cut his hair?”

Recovery Girl sighed and lowered her head. She looked… almost troubled, somehow. As if she was bearing a burden that she couldn’t share with them.

Izuku frowned. What was really going on?

“Kacchan”, he said, never taking his eyes off the old lady. “Ask… Ask her if we can go in”.

At the same time, Recovery Girl added:

“If you have any complaints about this, talk to Eraser Head or All Might”, she said tiredly. “This was a UA board decision. Now, if you’ll excuse me, I have patients to tend to”, she announced, turning to walk away.

Katsuki spared Izuku a look, bearing the same suspicion in his crimson eyes. Before Recovery Girl could leave, Katsuki called after her.

“Hey. Old lady. Can we go in?”, he asked, a bit too loudly. She turned to look at him, a hesitant expression on her face. Katsuki continued, forcing himself to sound polite: “I mean, Deku’s dying to see his body – no pun intended – and he’s been pissing me off about it for days, now. Maybe he’ll finally calm down if we just –“, he reached for the doorknob that led to Izuku’s room, but Recovery Girl stopped him, not being subtle about it at all.

Ok. Something was definitely going on. Katsuki had put on that little act instead of just kicking the door in because he wanted to see the heroine’s reaction… And it had worked. She clearly didn’t want him inside Deku’s room. This wasn’t about Katsuki giving him a haircut, compromising physical integrity or whatever bullshit she had fed him. This was about *seeing Deku*.

Why didn’t she want him to see Deku?

“Ok, what the hell is going on?”, he asked, hand still gripping the doorknob but not turning it. Recovery Girl stood in front of him, a serious glare on her face.

“Kacchan”, Izuku warned, worried. “Be careful”.

“Midoriya is not receiving any visitors now”, Recovery Girl explained, stern. “As I said, if you have any complaints, talk to Eraser Head or All Might. They will be able to help you more than I”.

Katsuki stared at her, studying her face and searching for any indications of what was really happening. Recovery Girl stared back at him with stern eyes, unfaltering beneath the boy’s glare.

“Kacchan”, Izuku said again, afraid that Katsuki was about to make a (rather explosive) scene and yell at the tiny old woman. Recovery Girl might look small and fragile, but Izuku was absolutely sure that Katsuki wouldn’t get away with disrespecting her. Plus, it was clear she didn’t want to – or perhaps couldn’t – talk to them about what was really happening. The best course of action would be to back off. “Let’s just go. We can talk to All Might about this”, Izuku added, watching Katsuki with worry.

Katsuki continued to stare at her.

“Even though it is Saturday, I am sure you must have afternoon classes, don’t you, Bakugou-kun?”, she asked pointedly. “You would better get going, lest you be late”.

“Yeah”, Katsuki said simply, suppressing a scoff and still studying Recovery Girl’s face.

“Kacchan”, Izuku called silently, tugging at Katsuki’s sleeve as if to urge him into moving.

“Well?”, Recovery Girl raised an eyebrow when Katsuki stayed glued on his feet.

“When will he be able to get visitors again?”, Katsuki stared at her, face impassive and eyes attentive. “Can I come back later?”

His question was clearly a test. He had no intentions of coming back later.

Recovery Girl sighed again, looking grievous and shaking her head. Her shoulders were slumped and she wore a disapproving look on her face. Neither Katsuki nor Izuku were sure if the disapproval was entirely aimed towards them. She didn’t look Katsuki in the eyes when she responded, sounding almost ashamed:

“Just ask one of your teachers about this, young man”.

And then she walked off.

As soon as she was out view, Katsuki twisted the doorknob to Izuku’s room in the infirmary and tried to open it.

It was locked.

Chapter End Notes

More mystery on the way!
(Also, Katsuki was refusing to look at Izuku in the beginning because he was embarrassed about the cuddling thing. They're both so oblivious... *sighs*)
Let me know what you think? I hope you guys liked this one!

Chapter 10: Todoroki Interrupts Bakugou's Shower

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Do you see anything?”

“No, lean me in a little deeper”.

“*You* can phase through walls, idiot, my hand can’t”.

“But I can’t see anything!”

“That’s not my fucking problem!”

“This was *your* idea, why are you complaining about it?!”

“Because you’re a fucking loser who can’t do anything right!”

“I don’t want to end up getting locked inside! What will you do if that happens? Just sit outside waiting forever without being able to walk away?”

“There’s no way you’ll end up locked inside, asshole. UA barely knows anything about the quirk that got you like this, how the fuck will they know how to lock you in?”

“There’s nothing wrong with wanting to be a little cautious about this!”

“There’s nothing wrong with me launching you in, either”.

“Kacchan, don’t you dare –“

“Oops! My hand slipped”, Katsuki announced in a monotone.

“Waah-chan!!!”

Katsuki, who had been holding Izuku’s hand while the boy leaned into the wall of his own medical room, released his grasp, making Izuku phase all the way through and fall inside the room. Izuku had been afraid to somehow end up locked in if he phased all the way inside the room, which was why he had Katsuki hold his hand outside while he tried to take a look at his body. Katsuki, on the other hand, knew there was no way Izuku would manage to assess the state of his own body if he just watched it from the door. Plus, if UA didn’t know how to fix him, it was extremely unlikely they knew how to lock Deku up in the first place, right?

Surely, they were being fishy as fuck about this whole Deku thing, and it was pissing Katsuki off. But they couldn’t see Deku’s soul, or touch him, or talk to him. They may be doing some messed up shit with his body, but they probably didn’t know how to control his soul. Katsuki knew the school would have shoved it back into Deku’s body and ended this entire gig if they knew how.

Deku's head emerged from the wall, the rest of his body remaining inside the medical room, in a way that much resembled Mirio. However, he had an upset expression on his face.

"Why did you do that for?", he complained.

"To make you stop being such a coward and get this shit over with quickly", Katsuki crossed his arms above his chest. "Now that you know you're not locked in, go check your shitty body out before the old lady comes back and catches me creeping in front of your room".

Izuku pointed Katsuki with a disapproving look before emerging back into the wall, disappearing from his view.

The medical room was empty, except for Izuku's body and the equipment required to keep him alive. Izuku felt really weird and extremely uncomfortable as he was painfully reminded of all the equipment it took for him to keep living – a respirator, intubation, series of IVs connected to him, and all sorts of machines he didn't know how to name.

In his soul-like state, he felt just fine – or at least, as fine as Kacchan felt. Either way, no matter *how* Kacchan felt, Izuku never felt like he was dying, or about to die, in any way. Now, staring down at his body, he was met with the horrifying realization of how close he was to death's door.

The weirdest part about this wasn't even staring down at his own self lying unconscious at a hospital bed, which said a *lot* about his state. The weirdest part about this was how unlike himself he looked.

His body looked pale, thin, and as fragile as paper. Izuku was suddenly convinced that, if Recovery Girl was to turn down the air conditioner one notch, his body wouldn't be able to survive the temperature change. He looked absolutely, horrifyingly *terrible*. The IV drip connected to his hand was probably his only sort of nourishment, and Izuku could see, with a painful twinge of his chest, how much muscular mass he had lost over the past week. It had only been one week since he got in a coma, and he already looked… half-dead.

It would certainly take him a ridiculous amount of time and training to make up for the lost muscles once he got out of this situation. But, from the look of his body… it would take him way more than a week to get out of that bed. His skin was so pale it was almost translucent; the skin around his eyes was purple and sunken; his hair had grown and it was falling over his eyes without any brightness or life. His arms and hands were so bony he looked like a skeleton already. He was thin. He was so thin. Looking at himself in that state, Izuku lost all certainty that he would ever get out of this situation.

Taking a step closer to the bed in order to examine himself, Izuku found that his nose was perfectly normal, unaffected by Katsuki's earlier punch. He tried to shove his body to the side a little so that he could see if there was a scar on his back, but his hand just phased through the fragile flesh. Weird how he could always touch Kacchan, but he couldn't touch his own body.

It was uncanny, seeing himself like that. So far, Izuku had been certain that All Might, the hero of heroes, would find a way to save him and put him back where he belonged. Hell, he

had been certain Kacchan would find a way, even if it was just to get rid of Izuku's soul. But from the way things were looking… Izuku wasn't certain of anything anymore. If anything, he looked like he was about to just… die, any second.

He ended up staring at his body and at his heart monitor for a long time, waiting for the moment his heart would give out. That was bound to happen, right? He looked so weak, so sick. He was sure his heart was about to give out any second now.

The sound of the machine aiding his breathing was sickening. The way his own chest rose and fell mechanically, just because of external aid, made his phantom skin tingle and the hairs at the back of his neck get up. The anticipation was killing him – the anticipation of seeing his own heart flatline. Out of a sudden, he could no longer stand being there, in the same room as his own body. He could no longer stare at himself. A deep sense of repulse invaded him, and Izuku walked back and phased himself out of the medical room so fast that his feet were acting before his brain caught up with his actions. Before he knew, he was already standing outside, face pale and eyes wide, his throat dry and his heart racing. He knew none of these feelings had any effect in his body – his heart monitor had been beating as normally as before.

He had never felt as disconnected from reality as in that moment.

"What?", Katsuki grabbed both of Izuku's shoulders, shaking him a little as if to catch his attention. Izuku's lost, scared gaze met Kacchan's, and he knew that it would be no use lying to him – not only could Kacchan feel exactly what he was feeling, but he could also see the fear etched in Izuku's face. "What is it, Deku?", Kacchan urged, shaking him again when Izuku didn't respond.

"I – I don't –", Izuku swallowed dry, not knowing how to put what he had seen into words. "I – I'm –"

"Ok, just take a fucking breath before I end up freaking out with you", Katsuki instructed, letting go of Izuku's shoulders but grabbing one of his wrists and dragging him away from the door of the room. "Think you can calm down enough to form coherent sentences 'til we get back to my room?", he asked, sparing Izuku's terrified face a quick glimpse as they walked towards the exit of Recovery Girl's medical bay.

"Y-Yeah", was all Izuku managed to spit out before he sealed his lips and fell into contemplative silence.

He thought he would be looking bad – after all, his soul wasn't in his body and he was in a coma –, but he hadn't thought it would be *that* bad. Now he could understand Uraraka's and Iida's concerns a little better. And now that he thought about it properly, he wondered how long had it been since any of his friends visited. He knew his mom hadn't been over in a while – he would have to ask her how long when he had the chance –, but had her ban been extended to his friends, too? Was the door locked only for Kacchan, or were his friends unable to see him as well? Was the deplorable state his body was in the reason for the ban? Was UA attempting to preserve his family and friends by not letting them see him? But then, why make up so many excuses?

They had told his mom that she couldn't see him because her going in and out of UA grounds all the time increased the risk of a villain attack. Recovery Girl had told Kacchan he couldn't see Izuku's body because cutting his hair would compromise his physical integrity (which they both now knew to be a lie). If they were just trying to protect Izuku's loved ones, there would be no reason to lie about it, right?

Unless his body's decay was more serious than Izuku thought. Unless… Unless there was something very wrong with him, something that UA couldn't afford his friends and family finding out. Unless…

Izuku didn't want to think about that.

"Just breathe, Deku", Katsuki instructed him, ever so aggressively, and only then did Izuku realize he was beginning to hyperventilate. The hand wrapped around his wrist grew tighter, as if meaning to ground him to reality. "We're almost there".

"Hey, Bakugou!", Kirishima called after them as they rushed by him at the entrance to the dorm building, Katsuki leading the way and all but dragging a stumbling Izuku after him. Despite of the half-concerned, half-angry glare painting Katsuki's face that screamed 'do not interact', Kirishima looked and sounded as cheerful as ever. "I can give you those notes now if you –"

"Not *now*, Kirishima", Katsuki barked without looking at his friend, entering the building in a rush and disappearing before Kirishima could say anything else.

They rushed the way up the stairs, ignoring all the people that crossed ways with them (which was a lot of people, since it was a weekend, and no one had classes for the time being). Kaminari had the audacity to follow them after Katsuki ignored him, which resulted on the explosive boy screaming a series of very graphic threats while Izuku continued to struggle to breathe behind him. Katsuki's hand never let go of Izuku's wrist, pulling him along once Kaminari ran away in fear and finally, *finally* entering his room. Only when they were inside did Katsuki let go of the boy, who stumbled his way to the bed and sat heavily on it, biting at one of his nails as he got lost in deep thought.

Katsuki locked the door behind them and made his way over to Izuku, shoving his hands into his pockets and glaring down at him. Despite of the anger on his face, there was also worry, which was a rare sight for him.

"So?", he asked, catching the nervous Izuku's attention and make him look up at Katsuki with apprehension in his eyes. "What'd you see in there that got you so worked up?"

"M-My body", Izuku managed to force out, making Katsuki sigh heavily and roll his eyes really hard.

"That's fucking expectable. Are you going to give me more details as to why my fucking heart is racing as if I'd just ran a marathon or what?", he spit. Deku took a deep breath in order to calm his heart, and his leg started bouncing rapidly as he tried to organize his thoughts and let out all the anxiety he was feeling somehow.

“Ok. So, I’ve been in a coma for a while now”, he began, making Katsuki tilt his head as if that was an obvious information.

“Yeah”.

“And that means I was supposed to look… *bad*, right?”, he continued, hesitant.

“*Yeah*”.

“But – I didn’t – I didn’t look *bad*”, Izuku looked up at Katsuki, honest apprehension etched all over his expressive eyes. “I looked *worse* than bad”.

“I don’t know what the fuck that’s supposed to mean”, Katsuki shrugged, eyeing Izuku with the same impassive expression.

“I looked dead, Kacchan”, Izuku said, voice almost wobbly. Kacchan frowned at him. He looked bothered by that, but tried to act as if he wasn’t.

“That’s also fucking expectable”, he shrugged again, feigning indifference.

“You don’t *understand*”, Izuku said with frustration, his voice raising as he stood up and began pacing around the room, looking nervous. “If – if anything goes wrong – if the power goes off for some reason, if someone as much as – as – pokes my body – I’m – I’m pretty sure –“, he trailed off, shaking his head and running a shaking hand through his messy hair. Katsuki approached him, a serious look on his face.

“Tell me how bad we’re talking”, he instructed, soundly strangely calm.

“*Really* bad”, Izuku said, not looking at him as he paced the room and bit his nails. “I mean, really, *really* bad. I don’t think my body was supposed to be looking *that* bad after such a short period of time”.

“So you think something’s wrong”, Katsuki concluded.

“Well”, Izuku shook his head again. “They’re not letting my mom in. Recovery Girl didn’t want to let you in. We don’t know if we’re letting anyone else in –“

“Which is suspicious as fuck”, Katsuki pointed out.

“*Yes*. I mean – they’re not even being subtle about it. And Recovery Girl gave us that terrible excuse and told us to talk to one of our teachers… So maybe they want us to find out what’s going on, but can’t tell us directly?”, Izuku suggested, turning to look at Katsuki.

“Like Aizawa sensei saying *that* back at the meeting”, Katsuki provided, looking away with a grim expression. Izuku felt his face pale even further. “He’s too smart to just let something fishy as that slip out, so it had to be on purpose”.

“To give us a hint?”, Izuku frowned.

“Maybe. Probably to give us an idea of what’s going on without directly telling us about it”, Katsuki took a pensive hand to his chin. “They’re a bunch of cowards who don’t have the balls to break the damn rules and just straight up tell us what’s going on”.

“You go to sleep at 8 p.m.”, Izuku pointed out, raising an eyebrow at Katsuki and making the boy snap his head towards him with a furious look on his face.

“What the fuck does that have to do with anything, shitty nerd?”, he yelled, angry.

“You can’t complain about the teachers not breaking the rules when you don’t break them either!”, Izuku explained, raising his hands in a gesture that indicated he meant no harm with his words.

“I can complain about whatever the fuck I want!”, Katsuki yelled in response. “Also, my sleep schedule doesn’t have anything to do with fucking rules, it has to do with maximized potential! And I break a damn lot of fucking rules!”

“Like which ones?”, Izuku shrugged.

“Well, I’m just about to break my no-punching rule right now and deck you in the face again!”, he announced, jumping at Deku.

“Hey!”, Deku yelled in response, dodging Katsuki’s blow and immobilizing his arm. Katsuki easily got free from the hold and pushed Deku away, holding his arms in front of him in a ready-to-fight gesture. “Can we *please* focus on the problem at hands?”, Izuku asked, frowning and not believing Kacchan actually wanted to *fight* him at a time like that. Katsuki came at him again, and Izuku barely managed to dodge the attack this time. “*Kacchan*!”

“What? Are you afraid to fight, shitty Deku?”, Katsuki scoffed, coming at him again.

“No, I’m just trying to focus on the fact that my body is withering away, and we have no idea what’s actually going on!”, Izuku protested, trying to immobilize Katsuki again. Katsuki got free by shoving Izuku away hard, making the boy collapse on the top of the bed.

“Well, and I’m trying to make you stop focusing on it, because I’m fucking tired of feeling anxious as fuck”, Katsuki announced, placing himself on the top of Izuku on the bed and immobilizing his arms and legs with his elbows and his knees. Izuku’s eyes widened slightly as he felt Katsuki’s weight pinning him down to the mattress.

“And y-your way to distract me is by fighting me?”, Izuku protested, heart racing. Kacchan’s face was extremely close to his, the boy’s breath tickling his lips. He tried to wriggle himself free of Kacchan’s hold and failed.

“Well, that’s what I do when I’m feeling anxious about shit that I can’t solve right away”, Kacchan scoffed, purposefully tightening his grip on Deku’s wrist. “I fight to release the tension. I fight to release the fucking stress. Maybe it works out for you, too. So why don’t you put some actual effort into your skinny butt for once in your life and see if you can finally beat me?”

“I don’t want to fight you!”, Izuku protested, frowning angrily. “I want to figure out what’s going on with my body!”

“You’re not gonna fucking figure anything out unless you take a break and calm the fuck down”, Katsuki tilted his head at him. “Pacing in my bedroom and looking like you’re about to break down into a sobbing fit isn’t gonna do anyone any good. What’s your plan, anyway? Walking into the UA board and screaming at the principal?”

“That sounds more like *your* plan”, Izuku said. “*My* plan is asking All Might about what’s really going on!”

“And he’s going to tell you that *why*?”, Katsuki provoked.

“Because he wouldn’t keep something like that from me!”, Izuku replied.

“Because you’re his heir, right?”, Katsuki scoffed again. “You’re his little chosen one. The inheritor of his power”.

“Yes!”

“Then *prove* it”, Katsuki smirked. “Because, from what I can tell, you’re nothing but the fucking *loser* who’s incapable of getting free from a simple immobilizing maneuver. Even a baby –“

Katsuki was cut off as Izuku headbutted him, making him release his grasp for a few shocked seconds and giving Izuku an opportunity to break free. Izuku turned on the bed and, using his legs, quickly made Kacchan lose his footing and fall. Before the boy could get up, Izuku launched himself at Katsuki and pinned him down instead, his knees holding Kacchan’s legs in place and one of his elbows pressing against Kacchan’s neck on the floor.

“*There*. Can we focus on my problem now?”, Izuku asked, giving Katsuki a serious look. Katsuki gave him a look that was full of rage for having been caught off guard, before grasping the arm that was pressing down on his neck with both hands. Izuku felt the palms grasping him increase heat until they were glowing, burning the skin of Izuku’s arms right before smoke erupted from it. Izuku quickly removed his arm and Kacchan took this chance to free himself from his hold, turning quickly on the floor before getting to his feet and aiming a fast kick at Izuku’s head. Izuku barely had the time to dodge the blow before Kacchan was investing again.

Before Izuku had the time to protest again, and before he knew better, he and Katsuki had engaged in a sparring session inside his bedroom. They never hurt each other too much, since they could literally feel each other’s pain, but it was enough to put their physical abilities and fighting proficiency to test. The sparring couldn’t have lasted more than five minutes, but by the end of it, Katsuki’s rolling chair had been knocked down, his mattress was a complete mess, the door of his wardrobe was open, and Izuku was lying on his back on the floor, panting heavily as Katsuki sat on the top of him, each of his knees on either side of Izuku’s body.

“What a great heir All Might chose”, Katsuki accused, panting as heavily as Izuku. He smirked evilly at the boy pinned beneath him. “Can’t even beat me at a fucking sparring session”.

“I wasn’t using One For All”, Izuku justified, face flushed and sweaty. His hair was blocking his vision, but he couldn’t swipe the curls away, since Katsuki was holding both of his hands above his head.

“If you need your fucking quirk to beat me in a one-on-one, then you’re not that good of a fighter”, Katsuki shrugged.

“Funny of you to say that”, Izuku accused tiredly, not even struggling against Katsuki’s grasp anymore. He could recognize a defeat when he saw one. “I thought quirks were everything to you”.

The smugness and the victory in Katsuki’s face evaporated at the words, leaving back a serious, unreadable expression.

“The hell does that mean?”, he frowned at Izuku, not letting go of him. If anything, his grasp tightened, as if to prevent the boy from escaping that conversation.

“Well”, Izuku averted his eyes from Katsuki, tilting his head away. His curls did the job of hiding his eyes away from view. “You stopped being my friend after you found out I was quirkless”.

“Yeah, *and*?”, Katsuki raised an eyebrow at him. Izuku tilted his head again to face Katsuki, resentment in his green eyes, which were half-covered by his hair.

“*And* you stopped being my friend because you thought that me not having a quirk meant I wasn’t at the same rank as you”, Izuku accused. Katsuki’s frown deepened.

“Yeah, and you weren’t”, he agreed without missing a beat. Izuku pretended the confirmation didn’t hurt him.

“Because if I didn’t have a quirk, I didn’t have any value”, he continued. “So that’s why I’m a little confused by *you* saying that I’m not good in a fight for relying on my quirk. Didn’t you do exactly that your entire life?”

Katsuki’s face fell upon Izuku’s words, and Izuku had to admit he felt a little bad for how accusatory he ended up sounding. He didn’t want to start yet another beef with Kacchan – he was just stating facts. Maybe their sparring had done them some good by balancing their emotions out, but now Izuku felt too tired and worn out to be careful with his words. Plus, when it came to Kacchan, it was always better to be honest than to be evasive.

Katsuki, however, was looking very troubled on the top of Deku, as if he had never thought about that before in his life. As if Izuku had just told him a hidden secret of the universe that had never crossed his mind, and that was only now unraveling a whole bunch of opportunities he had never gotten in touch with before. Without saying a word or even trying to defend himself, he slowly let go of Izuku’s wrists and unpinned him from the floor, staying

on the top of him with a pensive look on his face. Neither of the boys moved, Katsuki sitting on Izuku and Izuku not moving from beneath him.

They stayed like that for what felt like an eternity, but couldn't be more than seconds. Izuku was the first one to move, running both hands across his tired face and swiping his curls away from the top of his eyes with his fingers.

"Can we please focus on the fact that my body looks half-dead now? The sparring helped, but I'm still worried", he asked tiredly, staring up at Katsuki. The words seemed to finally urge some life into the boy, who realized he had been sitting on the top of Deku for too long and moved, getting back to his feet. To Izuku's surprise, Katsuki offered him a hand to aid him up, which he promptly accepted.

"I'm going to take a shower", Katsuki announced simply, not meeting Izuku's eyes. "Then we can figure out what to do about your shitty body".

Without waiting for a response, Katsuki grabbed himself some fresh clothes and walked into the bathroom, closing the door behind him. Izuku wanted to say something else, but he didn't know what. Instead, he simply sat at the edge of Kacchan's bed and waited, trying not to think too hard about the deplorable state his body had been in and about the rush of confusing emotions that were flashing through his chest.

Katsuki was in the middle of his shower when he heard a knock on his door.

"I'm in the fucking shower!", he screamed from inside the bathroom, aware that Deku wouldn't be able to get the damn door for him. However, a couple of seconds later, another series of knocks came, more urgent. "I'M IN THE GODDAMN FUCKING SHOWER!", he screamed louder, hoping that would make whoever the hell it was go away and leave him alone.

More knocks.

"God fucking damn it", he growled furiously, rinsing the remains of the shampoo off his hair and turning the water off. He walked out of the shower, wrapped a towel around his waist and yanked the bathroom door open, while a series of urgent knocks continued to come from his bedroom door. As he walked out of the steaming bathroom, he ignored the way Deku's eyes widened and his face became flushed as he spotted the half-naked Katsuki, and he headed to the front door while muttering: "This fucking dorm better be on fucking *flames* right now for this asshole to be in this much of a fucking hurry".

He yanked his door open with a furious scream of *WHAT?*, only to be faced with the figure of Icy Hot, who stared at him with surprise – or as much surprise as his stupid neutral face could muster – before studying Katsuki from head to toe as if he had any sort of right to analyze him. Katsuki snarled, but Todoroki simply raised an eyebrow at him, untroubled by the fact that he was wrapped in a towel with his hair dripping wet.

"I need to talk to you. Can I come in?", he asked neutrally and, without waiting for any sort of response, walked past Katsuki and walked straight in. Katsuki fumed, having to muster all his self-control not to blow up the door handle. He slammed the door close behind him with more strength than necessary, marching towards Todoroki, who had the audacity to look like he was judging Katsuki's bedroom for the messy state it was in after his sparring session with Deku.

"What the fuck do you want that's so fucking urgent?" Katsuki growled, snarling at the boy in front of him. Todoroki turned to face him, analyzing him for a moment.

"Does your bedroom always look like this?", he asked simply, untroubled by Katsuki's anger.

"No. If that's all you came here for, the fucking door is right over there", he growled again, nodding at the door. Todoroki sighed.

"That's not why I'm here", he said, staring at Katsuki. "I'm here because of Midoriya".

"Who?", Katsuki crossed his arms above his chest, squinting his eyes at Todoroki.

"Don't act stupid. This is serious", Todoroki replied. Katsuki snarled again.

"Who the *fuck* are you calling stupid?!", he yelled, looking like he was about to jump at Todoroki. Izuku launched himself from the bed and placed himself between Todoroki and Katsuki, his eyes darting between the two boys before focusing on Kacchan.

"Kacchan", Izuku called. "Just calm down and listen to what he has to say".

"Don't fucking tell me what to do, shitty Deku", Katsuki swatted Deku's hand away from his chest and took a step closer to Todoroki. "And Icy Hot better tell me what the fuck he's here for if he doesn't want me to blow his multicolored ass up", he added, glaring at the boy in front of him.

Todoroki was looking at the spot where he assumed Izuku was standing, eyes unable of seeing him. Upon Katsuki's words, however, he turned his eyes back towards him.

"I heard you went over to the infirmary today", Todoroki started, making Katsuki's eyes narrow.

"Who the fuck told you that?", he asked, suspicious.

"Some friends saw you heading in and out of there", Todoroki explained rapidly, as if that wasn't the point. "Were you allowed in Midoriya's room?"

“What the hell does it matter to you?”, Katsuki asked childishly. He couldn’t tell why, but Icy Hot really pissed him off, in the same way Deku used to do.

In a way Deku ***does***, he mentally corrected himself. Deku still pissed him off, right? It wasn’t like Katsuki was growing used to having him around and actually enjoyed his company, right?

Right???

“It matters because Midoriya is my friend and I worry about him”, Todoroki said simply.

“T-Todoroki-kun”, Izuku whispered simply from where he was standing beside Katsuki, admiration and fondness in his tone. Katsuki’s hands tightened into fists and he scowled so hard all his teeth were exposed in an ugly, angry snarl.

“Two days ago, I tried to visit, but Recovery Girl forbade me”, Todoroki continued, ignoring Katsuki’s anger (as usual). “Uraraka and Iida told me the same thing happened to them, and as you know, Mrs. Midoriya hasn’t been allowed to visit, either. Were *you* allowed in?”, he repeated his question.

“Kacchan”, Izuku stepped in before Katsuki could tell Todoroki off again. He was starting to feel Kacchan’s (unjustified) anger seep into him once more, but did his best to control himself and think rationally before both of them ended up losing their temper. “Just tell Todoroki-kun what happened. He could help us figure out what’s going on”.

“You’re not the fucking boss of me”, Katsuki snapped his head towards Izuku, angry. Izuku tightened his hands into fists and took a deep, calming breath before he ended up headbutting Kacchan again. That had hurt.

“*Just. Talk. To. Todoroki-kun. Kacchan.*”, Izuku said through gritted teeth, trying to think happy thoughts and ignoring the anger invading him and contaminating him.

“What is Midoriya telling you?”, Todoroki asked, eyes darting between Katsuki and the empty space that Izuku’s ghost was occupying, invisible to his eyes. So far, Todoroki seemed to be the best one at guessing Izuku’s location even though he was unable of seeing him.

“None of your damn business, Icy Hot”, Katsuki said angrily, crossing his arms above his (still wet) chest. He hated having to tell anything to that Half’n’Half bastard, but, much to his dismay, Deku was right. If their shitty friends had been telling the truth, then Icy Hot was the one who visited Deku the most. Maybe he could help them figure out what was going on, as much as Katsuki absolutely despised that option. “But no. The old lady didn’t let me in. Deku did phase through the wall and took a peek at his body like the disrespecting outlaw he is, though”, he added, pointing Deku with an evil smirk. Izuku’s eyes immediately widened, whereas Todoroki looked surprised and stood up straighter.

“You’re the one who talked me into doing that! I wanted to leave!”, Izuku protested.

“He did?”, Todoroki asked, attentive. “How was he?”

“Why do you care so much?”, Katsuki squinted his eyes at Todoroki, ignoring Deku.

“Because, as I said and you apparently didn’t comprehend, I’m Midoriya’s friend”, Todoroki answered, sounding slightly annoyed. Katsuki fumed, resulting on Izuku immediately holding him from behind and stopping him from jumping at Todoroki, even though the only thing keeping him from full-on nakedness was a single towel.

“If you came here to be fucking sassy, you’d better walk out the door before I blow you up so hard they’ll never find all the pieces!”, Katsuki shouted, trying to reach for Todoroki and failing. Todoroki’s eyes widened as he witnessed Katsuki being held back by an invisible force.

“It really is uncanny”, Todoroki narrowed his eyes, leaning forwards to take a better look at the way Katsuki’s struggling body was prevented from advancing by an invisible Midoriya. “The power he has over you”.

“*What*?! No one has any fucking power over me!”, Katsuki struggled harder against Izuku’s arms, feeling even more furious. Izuku’s grasp on Kacchan’s thin waist was faltering, but he did his best to keep him from murdering Todoroki (or trying to).

“Kacchan, stop struggling!”, Izuku shouted angrily, through gritted teeth. Kacchan’s anger was definitely in him now, and the only reason he wasn’t letting go of the feral boy was out of spite. “Just answer Todoroki-kun’s questions and let him speak!”

“I won’t tell him *shit* if he keeps putting up this smug act at me!”, Katsuki protested. “And get your shitty nerd hands off me, Deku, or I swear to fucking god I’ll kick your ass!”

“Let him go, Midoriya”, Todoroki said stoically, the first person to directly address the ghost-Izuku without hesitating or asking Katsuki about it first. For some reason, that infuriated the explosive boy even more. What, the Icy Hot bastard didn’t think he needed Katsuki’s help to talk to Deku? He thought he could just walk up into his room uninvited and talk to the nerd’s shitty ghost as if Katsuki was a mere intruder? Katsuki would fuck him up. Katsuki would fuck him *the fuck* up. “I can take him”, Todoroki added as calmly as ever, and ok. That was *definitely* the last straw.

Katsuki’s hands popped with explosions that he put no effort into controlling and he all but launched himself at Todoroki, Izuku still clinging to his back and being dragged behind him. He gave off a feral scream as he attacked, Todoroki looking ready to take him, but Izuku managed to stop Katsuki by throwing his full body weight on the top of the boy and making them both fall to the floor. Todoroki took a step to the side and watched the scene with slight surprise, since in his point of view, Katsuki had just fallen on his own.

“Kacchan, *stop*!”, Izuku said, sounding almost as angry as Katsuki felt. “Just listen to what Todoroki-kun has to say!”

“Get the *fuck* off me!”, Katsuki shouted, shoving Izuku to the side roughly. Todoroki sighed.

“I’ll just say what I need to say”, he announced, not looking intimidated when Katsuki got back to his feet. Izuku held one of Katsuki’s wrists before he could invest against Todoroki

again. “I think UA is not telling us everything there is to know about Midoriya’s state. Uraraka and Iida think so as well. We have been noticing an increasing decrease of his health with each passing day for the past week, until we were banned from visiting. You don’t have to tell me what Midoriya saw in his room today for me to assume that he’s probably gotten worse. I have been thinking about the reasons why UA wouldn’t let Midoriya’s friends and family visit him and I’ve reached a conclusion”.

“Which is?”, Katsuki raised an impatient eyebrow at him. Todoroki gave him a serious, almost reproaching look.

“They don’t want you to know”, Todoroki said simply. Katsuki frowned.

“Well… That’s obvious, right? They don’t want anyone to know”, Izuku frowned in confusion, turning to face Kacchan. Katsuki, however, had a very serious, displeased look on his face, which earned on Izuku’s confusion increasing. “Kacchan…?”, he asked hesitantly, noticing Katsuki had clearly interpreted Todoroki’s words in a way that he hadn’t.

“Shut up, Deku”, Katsuki said simply, eyes still glued on Todoroki, who continued:

“They’re aware, better than anyone, of your explosive temperament. So what’s happening to Midoriya must be really serious, if they don’t want you to know”.

“I get not telling *you*, but why not tell anyone else?”, Izuku asked Katsuki, still frowning. “I mean, my mom had the right to know –“

“They’re not telling anyone because they don’t want to risk anyone telling *me*, Deku”, Katsuki responded simply, eyes still glued on Todoroki. “And if they don’t want to risk me knowing, then it must be serious as *fuck*”, he turned to stare at Izuku, an unreadable look in his eyes.

“I agree”, Todoroki nodded, stern. “If they don’t want you to know, then whatever is making Midoriya bad so fast is probably serious enough for even you to want to step in”.

“*Eeh*?!”, Katsuki asked, offended. Izuku’s grasp on his wrist tightened.

“Ok, but why not tell my mom? She deserves to know!”, Izuku pointed out. “*And* I doubt she would tell you about it. I sort of get them not telling my friends about it, since they could end up telling you… But leaving my mom in the dark is cruel!”

“The shitty nerd is right”, Katsuki turned back to Todoroki. “His mom doesn’t know anything about it, and she’s not exactly *fond* of me. She wouldn’t tell me anything, so why not let her know of her son’s state?”

“I don’t know”, Todoroki admitted. “All I’ve told you is speculation. There’s no way to be sure about what’s really happening, unless we… do something about it”, he added. Katsuki narrowed his eyes at him, at the same time Izuku’s eyes widened.

“What do you mean?”, he asked, even though Todoroki couldn’t hear him.

“The fuck do you have in mind, Icy Hot?”, Katsuki raised an eyebrow at him. Todoroki sighed.

“Uraraka and Iida, as well as some of the other people in class, think it’s best if we confront Aizawa sensei about it, since he’s part of the UA board”, he started, not sounding too fond of that idea.

“But you don’t think that’ll work”, Katsuki affirmed.

“No, I don’t”, Todoroki nodded briefly. “I think Aizawa sensei won’t risk you getting involved, if it really is that serious”.

“So what do you have in mind?”, Katsuki urged, yanking his wrist away from Izuku’s grasp so that he could cross his arms above his naked chest. Todoroki eyed him for a few seconds, as if trying to decide whether he should speak up or not. Katsuki rolled his eyes. “Look, you already came all the way here and made me cut my fucking shower short. You might as well just speak the hell up already”.

“I was thinking of a more decisive solution”, Todoroki said, serious. “Something that no one else will be up to, probably”.

“Which is?”, Katsuki tilted his head impatiently as an encouragement for Todoroki to continue.

“Sneak into a board meeting and listen to what they say”, Todoroki concluded.

Katsuki stared at him for a long time, eyes narrowing. Izuku looked nervous beside him.

“You can’t do this”, Izuku said nervously, eyes darting between Todoroki and Katsuki. “If you get caught, you could be expelled!”

“You and Midoriya have a distance limit, don’t you?”, Todoroki continued, unaware of Izuku’s objection.

“Kacchan, you can’t do this. It’s too risky. And if you get expelled, we’ll not only be even farther away from my body, but you’ll throw away your chance of being a pro hero! No other school will accept you! It’s better if we stick around and find what’s going on some other way –“

“We do”, Katsuki said, completely ignoring Izuku’s objections and seriously listening to Todoroki’s proposal.

“*Kacchan*!”

“So we could stay away at a safe distance from the room where the board holds their meetings, and Midoriya could sneak inside without them knowing about it, right?”, Todoroki added, and Izuku could see it in Kacchan’s crimson eyes, he could *see* how seriously he was considering that proposal.

“Kacchan”, Izuku stepped in front of Kacchan, rather than standing beside him, blocking Todoroki from his view and looking extremely serious. “I’m more curious than you, *trust* me, and this is *my* life on the line. But I won’t let you throw your career on the trash just because of me”.

Katsuki scowled at Izuku and scoffed with indifference, looking at him as if he was a ridiculous little thing who had just stepped in his way.

“You think way too much of yourself, shitty Deku”, Katsuki accused, making Izuku angrily shake his head.

“Why can’t you just *listen* to me?!”, he protested.

“If I know Midoriya, he is probably complaining about this being too risky”, Todoroki continued, making Izuku blush slightly. “But we don’t have to do this recklessly. Based on the maximum distance that you can get between each other, we can find an empty room on the floor *beneath* the board meeting room, and sneak Midoriya in through the ceiling. If they are patrolling the place to prevent you, or any of us, from sneaking around, they will probably patrol the floor of the meeting, and not the floor beneath”.

“You’ve been putting a lot of thought into this”, Katsuki accused, glaring at Todoroki.

“I’m concerned about Midoriya’s state”, he replied simply, giving no further details. Katsuki scoffed.

“This is still too risky”, Izuku shook his head, biting at one of his nails and looking conflicted. “I don’t like this plan; it could backfire and you two could end up being expelled! I don’t want you to risk your futures for me!”

“We’ll think about it”, Katsuki said simply, continuing to ignore Izuku.

“No, we *won’t*! I’m not doing it!”, Izuku protested.

“Good. I didn’t expect you to agree to this right away, anyway”, Todoroki admitted. “Talk to me when you’ve made up your mind”.

“Fine. Was that all you wanted to talk about?”, Katsuki asked, rather impolitely. Todoroki seemed untroubled by this, and nodded, looking ready to leave.

“Yes, that’s all. I’ll leave you alone, now”, he announced, walking past Katsuki again and heading to the door. Before he could open it, however, Katsuki interrupted him.

“Hey. Icy Hot”, he called, making Todoroki turn to face him. Katsuki stared at the boy with a mature seriousness in his eyes, which contrasted heavily with his usual poorly-managed anger. “You said no one else will be up to this shit. What makes you think I will?”

Todoroki simply stared at him for a few moments, as if lost in deep thought.

“As loyal as our friends are, I don’t believe they’re ready to risk their futures as pro heroes this way”.

Katsuki chuckled humorlessly, disbelief and mockery evident in his tone. He gave Todoroki a bitter smirk as he responded.

“What, and you think I am ready to risk mine? For *Deku*?”

Todoroki continued to stare at him.

“All I can tell you is that I, for one, know Midoriya’s life is worth the risk”.

The smirk disappeared from Katsuki’s face. Todoroki twisted the doorknob, walked out, and closed the door behind him without saying anything else.

Katsuki stared at Izuku, and Izuku stared at Katsuki. Neither of them knew what to say.

“Fucking Half’n’Half weirdo”, Katsuki said simply, walking back towards the bathroom. Izuku followed him before he could close the door.

“Kacchan. We need to talk about this”, he said, a serious look on his face.

“There’s nothing to talk about”, Katsuki said with a bored expression.

“Yes, there is!”, Izuku protested. “I’m not allowing –“

“*You* don’t have the right to allow *any fucking thing*, you damn nerd”, Katsuki interrupted with a sharp glare. Before Izuku could present any protests, he added: “And you’re right”.

“I… am?”, Izuku frowned, taken aback by hearing such words from Kacchan.

“Yeah. Icy Hot’s plan is too risky. I’m not doing it”, he announced simply. Izuku’s face fell and he blinked in surprise.

“Oh”, he said, face blank. “Oh, okay”.

“What? You really think I’m gonna risk my fucking license for your nerdy ass?”, Katsuki raised an eyebrow at him, giving him one pitiful scoff. “C’mon, Deku”.

“No, I mean – you – you’re right”, Izuku nodded, forcing himself to look serious and convinced as he met Katsuki’s eyes again. “It’s too risky. You shouldn’t do it”.

“I know”, Katsuki gave him an unimpressed look. “Now can you let me finish my fucking shower in peace or do you plan or staying in the damn bathroom to watch?”

Izuku’s cheeks burned in embarrassment and he took a series of steps back until he was standing out of the bathroom, an apologetic look on his face.

“Oh, right, s-sorry, Kacchan”, he apologized, unable to meet Katsuki’s eyes.

“We’ll talk to All Might later”, Katsuki announced without looking at Izuku, his tone sounding almost as if he wanted to reassure him. “See if his soft spot for you makes him run his mouth about what’s really going on”.

“O-Okay”, Izuku nodded. Without further ado, Katsuki closed the bathroom door, leaving Izuku alone with his thoughts.

Izuku sat back at the edge of the bed, his mind rushing at hundreds of miles per hour. Had he really expected Kacchan to risk his future as a hero just because of him? They were in better terms now – they were not actually friends, but they were more… used to each other’s presence? –, but that didn’t mean Kacchan was willing to sacrifice his life-long dream just to have an idea of what was happening to Izuku.

As much of a bad boy as Kacchan liked to act, Izuku knew he wasn’t the rule-breaker type. He may be rude and insolent, but ever since they had been accepted into UA, he had never actually done anything that could have given him any risk of being expelled. Back when they studied together at their regular school, he had been a bit of a punk… bullying people (mostly Izuku), hanging out with the wrong sort of people, getting himself into some small trouble that wouldn’t end up in his record… Now that they were at UA, it was almost like he was trying to keep himself out of trouble. Going to bed early was only one of the many things Kacchan did that broke his image of a bad boy.

Izuku should have expected Kacchan not to want to risk his license for Izuku, of all people. He barely even tolerated Izuku, right? It made no sense to expect Kacchan would actually risk throwing his dream in the trash because of him. If anything, now Izuku felt a little pathetic and embarrassed for begging Kacchan not to accept Todoroki’s invitation. He should have known there was no way he’d accept it in the first place, right?

Still… he couldn’t deny that he was a little disappointed that Kacchan had so easily turned the proposal down. He couldn’t stop thinking about Todoroki’s words…

I, for one, know Midoriya’s life is worth the risk.

Kacchan had known Izuku his whole life. They knew each other since they were little kids. They grew up together, they had a story together, even if it wasn’t the best or the healthiest one.

Todoroki had known Izuku for less than a year. He wanted to be a hero just as much as any of them. And he was easily willing to throw his future away for the hypothetical chance of figuring out what was wrong with Izuku. He wasn’t risking his future to save Izuku – he was risking his future for a *chance* of saving him.

Izuku lowered his head, forcing himself not to feel sad, lest Kacchan find out about his upset mood. He had begged Kacchan not to accept Todoroki’s suggestion. He had insisted that he didn’t take part in Todoroki’s plan. Why was he so sad that Kacchan had listened to him for once?

This was for the better. If Kacchan didn’t get involved, Todoroki wouldn’t be able to go forwards with the plan, and therefore neither of them would be under any risk of being expelled. Izuku should be happy, right? Neither of his friends would be risking themselves because of him. He should be *happy*.

But he couldn’t help but feeling hurt.

He reached the conclusion that this was because of Kacchan's rapidness to decide Izuku wasn't worth the risk. It took him what? One, two minutes of thinking to decide Izuku's life wasn't worth losing his chance of becoming a hero for? And Izuku couldn't blame him, didn't want to blame him, but still, a deep, hidden, utterly selfish part of himself wished that Kacchan would at least consider, would at least have the slightest, littlest desire to risk his license just to save him. This ugly, selfish part of himself wished that Kacchan cared enough about him to consider – even if he didn't *actually* go through it! – to risk himself just to save him.

Izuku knew this was just a dream.

Because as much as the years passed, as much as the distance between himself and Kacchan got smaller and smaller, as much time as they spent (forcefully) together, Izuku knew they were too far gone. There was no way they could go back, there was no way they could reverse the event horizon they had crossed back when Kacchan found out Izuku was quirkless. Any chance of having a friendship with Kacchan died on that day. Any chance of having *anything* with Kacchan died on that day.

And yes, it was stupid, and pathetic, and ridiculous, and meaningless for Izuku to want Kacchan to love him in the same way he loved Kacchan, because they had passed that point of no return a long, long time ago. It didn't matter how hard Izuku admired him, and looked up to him, and worried about him, and cared for him – Kacchan would never return those feelings, because to him, Izuku was nothing but a rival. They had been friends once, a long, long time ago, and then Izuku became nothing, and now Izuku was something, something Kacchan used as encouragement, something Kacchan used as a way to push himself harder and farther, something Kacchan used as a stepping stone. Besides that… Izuku had no use to him, and he was definitely not someone worth risking himself for.

He wished he didn't feel as upset as he felt on that moment. He had known about all that, right? He had *always* known. He was the one who begged Kacchan not to risk himself in order to save him.

But what bothered him, he figured, was that Kacchan never wanted to save him in the first place.

He ended up crying silently, despite of himself, feeling his heart break all over again. This was stupid. He felt stupid. He tried to control his pain so that it wouldn't be too overwhelming and so that Kacchan wouldn't feel it as well, because the last thing he needed on that moment was for the boy to burst out of the bathroom screaming demands for Izuku to tell him what was wrong. What could he possibly say in response?

What could he possibly say to Kacchan at all?

Izuku didn't even find himself astonished by the realization he loved Kacchan. He had always known that, right? He had to know, at some level, and he had to love him, at some level. There was no way he would have stuck around and kept admiring the person who bullied him and put him down if it wasn't out something as strong and as twisted as love. It wasn't good, and it wasn't healthy, but it was there, and Izuku could do nothing about it. He couldn't even tell if his love for Kacchan was the same one he had for his mom, or for All

Might – but it was definitely there, and it was definitely love. If it was something new or something different… he didn't know just yet. He didn't think he wanted to find out. What for? Kacchan would never love him back – neither as a friend or as… as something else.

All he could do was hope Kacchan would stop breaking his heart at some point.

He was getting better, but not quite there just yet. Not quite there.

Katsuki could feel the tears rolling down his cheeks, but preferred to pretend they were just water from his boiling-hot shower.

He had more important things to focus on instead of Deku's sappy feelings, he told himself as he rinsed the hair conditioner from his hair and focused on the sensation of his skin burning, which was better than the sensation of his heart breaking. He had a lot of important things to think about.

How to find out what the hell was going on with the nerd and fix him before something bad happened to him was the top priority on his mental list.

Deku had felt so distraught and nervous when he'd been inside his hospital room. Katsuki had felt all of it. He had experienced all of it, and he thanked whatever fucking deity was out there for Recovery Girl not letting him inside that hospital room. He wasn't sure he would have handled it, seeing Deku's body – especially after Deku's own description – and not losing his shit again. Not with the memories in his head. Not with the images in his mind.

Katsuki didn't want to feel anything like Deku's fear again. He didn't think he quite wanted Deku to feel it, too, even if he wouldn't tell him as much.

Katsuki didn't confront Izuku about the crying as he stepped out of the bathroom, now fully dressed in fresh clothes and a trail of steam following him into the bedroom. Izuku didn't

mention it either, or address him at all. He was trying to hide it, but Katsuki could tell he had been crying.

(He didn't have to look at Izuku to know that much, though).

Since he had already told the nerd where they were going after he was done with the shower, Izuku followed him silently out of the room when Katsuki opened the door, no questionings. Katsuki found it weird, but decided he wouldn't complain about small miracles. He'd been asking Deku to shut his trap, and he was finally attending his many requests. That was good, right? It didn't matter that his chest was fucking heavy with sadness, *this. Was. Great*.

They would have enough time to talk to All Might before the afternoon classes began, and maybe Katsuki could even manage to grab lunch before that. He wasn't hoping to get much out of the number one hero, though. His soft spot was for Deku, not Katsuki, and he couldn't really see Deku's stupid puppy eyes, even though Katsuki was sure he could imagine them. Still, trying his chances with All Might sounded like a better plan than Icy Hot's suicidal mission of getting expelled for one piece of information. If Deku's life was really under some sort of risk, then All Might would be the first person to want and help him, right? Maybe if Katsuki acted more patient, more well-composed and less-short fused, they could manage to talk All Might into spilling the beans.

All Might wasn't in his office, which was bad for Katsuki's plan, but he was in the teacher's room when Katsuki peaked inside. With him were Present Mic and Midnight, the rest of the teachers being nowhere to be seen. Present Mic didn't notice Katsuki's head on the door, but All Might and Midnight did. Thankfully, Katsuki didn't have to knock on the door, step inside, or even announce his presence before All Might was on his feet and walking towards them. Midnight didn't say anything as he left, but she kept her eyes glued to him like a hawk as the hero walked out of the teacher's room and closed the door behind him.

"Young Bakugou", All Might greeted him in his true form. Even though Katsuki hadn't grown exactly used to seeing All Might so bony and lanky, he could notice that the man's eyes were more sunken and he looked more tired than usual. "How can I help you? Is everything all right with you and Young Midoriya?"

"Can we talk?", Katsuki said instead of offering All Might a proper response or a greeting. The concerned frown that flashed over the man's face made Katsuki feel victorious – maybe, if he was concerned enough about the situation, he would fill Katsuki in about what was truly happening. "I mean, somewhere private", Katsuki added, hoping the mystery in his tone would convince All Might that this was something serious.

All Might sighed and looked around, as if checking for any witnesses. He looked hesitant for a moment before gesturing for Katsuki to follow him and heading back silently to his own office. Izuku was still very silent beside Katsuki as they followed the number one hero, but he looked a bit less miserable than before. It was amazing how seeing All Might, even in his natural, bony form, completely cheered Izuku's mood up.

They entered All Might's office and Katsuki sat down directly in front of him, Izuku sitting beside him. Now that they were alone and in private, Katsuki could tell just how utterly

exhausted and miserable All Might looked. As if he hadn't taken a break for the entirety of the past week.

"So, Young Bakugou", All Might encouraged when Katsuki stayed silent in front of him, his eyes darting across the office and taking in every bit of information there was to take. "What did you want to talk about?"

Katsuki glared at All Might, still feeling angry at his – and UA's – secrecy despite of the man's clear misery. He leaned back against the couch in a comfortable position, looking like he was at his own home.

"I want to know what's really going on with Deku", Katsuki said, his tone of voice leaving no place for discussions or bullshit. Maybe he shouldn't be so direct with a teacher, especially when said teacher was also the number one hero, but he had been way more disrespectful to All Might before.

All Might sighed and lowered his head, facing away from Bakugou as if to prevent the boy from looking into his eyes and realizing there was something wrong. But the joke was on him – everyone already knew there was something wrong. There was no use hiding the truth from them anymore.

"I went over to the infirmary a while ago", Katsuki continued, his voice heavy with suspicion, when All Might didn't say anything. "Recovery Girl didn't let me in Deku's room. Deku's shitty friends told me the same thing happened to them. And when I visited Deku's mom this week, she said UA wasn't letting her in anymore. Something fishy is obviously going on here, and since I'm the one who's stuck with carrying Deku around like a babysitter, I think I deserve to know what it is", he concluded. His eyes were fixed on All Might, but All Might only looked at him when he was done talking.

"I understand your demands, Young Bakugou", he agreed, nodding solemnly. "And I agree that neither you, your friends, or Mrs. Midoriya should be kept in the dark. However…", Katsuki clicked his tongue and scoffed with indifference before All Might even had the chance to feed him whatever bullshit he was about to make up. "I'm going to ask you to trust the school on this matter. We are working incessantly –"

"I don't care", Katsuki interrupted, leaning forwards on the couch. "We all know Deku's body is getting worse with each passing day", he opted to hide the fact that Izuku had phased through the wall to see his own body, just in case All Might spilled that information to someone and resulted on Katsuki being banned from going to the infirmary. "And since his ass is stuck to me, I have the right to know what's really going on. I'm tired of being told to 'trust the school' without being given any damn actual reason to".

All Might's lips formed a thin, stern line and he looked to the side again, looking conflicted.

"Listen, Young Bakugou –", he started, and Katsuki immediately suppressed a sigh. "I want you to know what is really happening, but I can't tell you all the details. Right now, UA is coordinating an undercover, very secret mission to retrieve the villain who attacked you and Young Midoriya. Not even the media has been informed, despite of the pressure they are

putting on us for a solution. If we tell anyone about the details, we could end up compromising the operation and not catching the bandit".

"I'm not asking you to give me the war plans or some shit", Katsuki shook his head. "Just to tell me why the hell no one can see Deku's body".

All Might lowered his head again. There was a weird, paradoxical look of determination and hesitation in his eyes.

"All I can tell you is that Young Midoriya's body is getting more compromised with each passing day. The state of his health is deteriorating, which is why we are doing our best to capture this villain as soon as possible. The reason why we kept his mother and his friends from seeing him…", he sighed heavily, as if he was carrying the weight of the world in his shoulders. "Is because his immune system has already been compromised. We can't risk him catching an infection, or…", he trailed off. Katsuki decided he didn't need to continue.

So Deku's absolute distraught upon seeing his own body hadn't been an exaggeration. He really was looking *that bad*. Katsuki was once again glad that Recovery Girl didn't allow him into the room… the last thing he needed was more memories of a dying Deku to haunt him.

He turned his head to look at Izuku, whose eyes were wide and whose brow was scrunched up with fear and concern. His fingers were idly playing with the hem of his shirt as he stared up at All Might, looking like there was nothing in the world he longed for more than a hug from his mentor. Katsuki sighed.

"He's right beside me, you know", he told All Might, looking serious and still angry. "You don't have to talk as if he isn't here".

All Might looked surprised and embarrassed for a moment before giving Katsuki a small apologetic smile, scratching the back of his neck and looking like he had been caught red handed doing something wrong.

"I'm sorry, my boy", All Might said, and both Katsuki and Izuku knew who he was addressing now. "I believe I spent so much time with your unconscious body that I…", he trailed off again.

"You look tired, All Might", Izuku said, concern etched in his tone. "Are you taking care of yourself?"

Katsuki turned his head to give Izuku an incredulous look.

"Do you want me to ask him that? Because there's no way I'm asking him that".

"He needs to look after himself, Kacchan!", Izuku protested, still worried. "Look at him! He looks like he hasn't slept in days!"

"Yeah, because he's busy trying to save your ass", Katsuki pointed out.

"I *know* that", Izuku responded, a bit more bitterly and aggressively than Katsuki had expected. "*That's* why I'm so worried".

Without saying anything else or insisting, Izuku turned his head away and crossed his arms above his shoulder, looking pissed. Something definitely was going on with him. Katsuki would have to ask about it later.

“Fine”, Katsuki sighed in resignation and gave All Might a bored, bitter look. “Deku wants to know if you’re taking proper care of yourself”.

All Might smiled again at this, even though he looked sadder than anything else. A clear and deep look of fondness smoothed out the rough edges surrounding his eyes and he shook his head slightly, looking like he wanted to scold Izuku for worrying about everyone except for himself, but he didn’t have the heart to.

“Ah, my boy”, he commented with fatherly affection, sounding proud and disapproving at the same time, if that was possible. “You never change, do you?”

“No, he doesn’t”, Katsuki responded before Izuku could say anything, giving All Might a no-shit look. “He keeps playing the self-sacrificing act even though he’s the one with his foot half-kicking the damn bucket”.

All Might studied Katsuki silently for a few moments before speaking up again.

“You still have a long path to go, Young Bakugou”, he commented. “If you really think Young Midoriya’s altruism is an *act*. You, of all people, should know from first-hand experience that being selfless is something that he cannot help but doing”.

Katsuki looked away from All Might at the words, feeling angry for being embarrassed. He could recognize there was truth behind the number one hero’s statement, but was too stubborn to acknowledge it in front of him.

“E-Even – Even if what he said about my immune system being compromised is true”, Izuku said, suddenly deciding he wanted to speak to Katsuki again. He probably realized he had no other choice, if he wanted to get his message to All Might relayed. “Why not tell my mom, or anyone else about it? Why make up so many different lies, why clearly show us they’re lying, instead of coming clean? I’m sure my mom and the others would have understood and kept their distance if UA had just told them they can’t see me because my immune system is compromised. Why be so mysterious about it?”

Katsuki frowned at Izuku before looking at All Might again.

“Yeah, Deku’s right”, Katsuki said, pointing their teacher and mentor with a look filled with suspicion. “If the only reason you’re telling Deku’s visitors off is to preserve his immune system, why the hell did you guys lie to everyone about it? And why the hell not tell Deku’s mom about what’s going on? When we went over to pay her a little visit, she looked like a train wreck”, Katsuki scowled. Izuku glared at him.

“Kacchan”, he said, a warning in his tone. Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“What? It’s true. She was horrible. She probably hasn’t been sleeping and she looked tired as fuck, all because you assholes have been keeping her in the dark about Deku’s state”, Katsuki

accused.

“The only reason we didn’t tell anyone is because we can’t risk the villain learning of Young Midoriya’s state”, All Might explained vaguely, making Katsuki throw his hands up and down in annoyance.

“Why *not*?”, he urged, angry. He could tell All Might had fed him half-truths instead of telling him what was really going on. He could just *tell*. “Just tell us what’s really going on”.

“What is going on is more complicated than you believe, young men”, All Might sighed tiredly, pinching the bridge of his nose and leaning forwards on his seat with a grumpy expression. “I can’t tell you everything because, if the information leaks out, we could risk our chance of ever capturing this villain and saving Young Midoriya’s life. This is a very delicate operation we are coordinating, and any misstep –“, he cut himself off, sounding like he couldn’t say much more. Both Katsuki and Izuku stared up at him with expectation.

“All Might”, Izuku whispered.

“Any misstep *what*?”, Katsuki urged, apprehensive. He didn’t like All Might’s tone. It had tragedy carved all over it.

Instead of responding, All Might stood up from his seat and kept his head bowed, looking like it was taking all of his self-control to keep what he knew to himself. Katsuki stayed where he was, waiting for the hero to continue.

“Just… *trust* UA, shonen. I can assure you we are doing our best to capture this villain and put an end to this terrible story”, All Might said, rather evasively. “I am sure we can count on your discretion regarding what I told you today. Any leak of information could –“

“You didn’t tell me anything I didn’t already know”, Katsuki stood up, Izuku mimicking him. He threw his hands into his pockets and stared up at All Might with a defiant glare. “So Deku’s body is shit right now, big surprise. I want to know the reason for all the lies. Most of all – I want to know the reason for the shittiness of the lies”, he scoffed. “Because y’all didn’t put any effort into making it convincing, at least. It’s like you’ve been dropping clues for us to catch, breadcrumbs for us to follow. Recovery Girl told me to talk to you and ask about the real reason why I couldn’t see Deku”, Katsuki concluded, sounding serious and insolent. “Are you going to tell me, or will I have to find out on my own?”

“I would watch my tone if I were you, Young Bakugou”, All Might said sternly, but there was something akin to guilt in his voice that washed away all the threat he had mustered into his tone. “I told you all that I could. Having this conversation with you on its own is breaking the rules. Just know that we are doing all that we can to ensure Young Midoriya’s wellbeing, as well as yours”.

“*Knowing* it is not enough”, Katsuki squinted his eyes. “I want to see actual proof”.

“We will show you proof once we capture the villain and restore Young Midoriya’s soul to his body”, All Might reassured him. “You can have my word”.

“Tch”, Katsuki scoffed. Izuku called his attention from beside him.

“Kacchan”, Izuku called, a serious look on his face. “Ask him… Ask him to tell that to my mom. She deserves to know why she can’t visit me. And she won’t tell anyone about it, if she knows it could interfere on the capture. Just…”, Izuku bit his lower lip, looking conflicted. “Tell him I’m the one who’s asking him that”.

Katsuki studied Izuku’s on-the-way-to-sobbing face for a moment before turning back to All Might.

“Now, if that was all –“, All Might started, but Katsuki interrupted.

“There’s something else”, he said seriously, still glaring up at the hero and looking very suspicious. “Deku wants you to tell his mom”.

All Might hesitated, looking to the side where he assumed Izuku was standing without being able to see him.

“Young Midoriya…”

“She deserves to know and you know it”, Katsuki interrupted. “Also, it’s *Deku* asking, not me. He’s been worried sick about her, and she’s been worried sick about him. Telling her she can’t see him because of germs or whatever is better than leaving her in the dark like you’re doing to the rest of us”.

“The board decided it would be better if we gave her no reasons to be so worried”, All Might said, eyes darting between Katsuki and the empty space where Izuku was standing, looking like he wasn’t sure who he should address. “That’s why we said nothing. To know her only son is in such a fragile state…”

“Her son’s soul is literally detached from his body”, Katsuki pointed out with another scoff. “What could be worse than that?”

Ah, shonen. If only you knew, All Might thought to himself. Instead of voicing his thoughts, he bowed his head again and nodded briefly, if only to please Katsuki enough for him to leave before he ended up saying too much.

“You are right. A mother deserves to know about her son’s health. I will contact Mrs. Midoriya and inform her of Young Midoriya’s state, and the real reason behind her ban”, All Might promised.

“T-Thank you, All Might”, Izuku said, sounding sincere. “Thank you very much”.

“He’s thanking you”, Katsuki said grumpily, looking bored and annoyed. All Might nodded again.

“You are welcome, Young Midoriya”, he said, going back to standing up straight. “Now, shonen. I am afraid I can’t be of much use for you now. If you don’t have any more questions, I believe it is time for your afternoon classes”, he said dismissively, pointing to the door. Katsuki and Izuku walked towards the exit and All Might followed them, meaning to

head back to the teacher's room. As they stepped out, however, Katsuki turned to face All Might once again, suspicion and anger (which was constant) clear in his crimson eyes.

"All Might", he called as the man finished the process of closing the door behind himself.

"Yes, shonen?", All Might replied.

"You said the villain can't know about Deku's state, or it could risk the capture", Katsuki continued, narrowing his eyes. "Why is that?"

All Might sighed again, sounding tired.

"That is one of the things you can't know just yet, my boy", was his vague response. Katsuki scoffed.

"He also said something about saving my life", Izuku asked, giving Katsuki an apprehensive look. "My life must be in danger if it needs to be saved, right?"

"Yeah", Katsuki agreed, eyes still glued on All Might. "What do you have to say about that?"

"About what?", All Might frowned, not having heard Izuku's words. Katsuki rolled his eyes. He hated when he forgot that not everyone could see or hear the damn nerd.

"You said something about saving shitty Deku's life", Katsuki explained. "Is he actually dying?"

All Might looked away again, a conflicted look in his eyes. Somehow, that haunted look on his face told Katsuki everything he needed to know.

"Young Midoriya's state is getting worse with each passing day", All Might said simply, not looking at them. "Which is why we are doing our best to capture the villain as fast as possible".

"And if you don't?", Katsuki insisted, sounding more skeptical than he actually felt. They would capture this villain, right? They *had* to. This was UA they were talking about. This was *All Might*. There was no way some shitty D-lister would be the one to cause Deku's death, right?

Katsuki couldn't allow that. As much as he fucking hated to admit it, now he knew – he remembered – that shitty Deku was only in this situation because of him. Sure, he had jumped in front of Katsuki out of his own free, stupid will, but he had *jumped* anyway. If it hadn't been for Deku, it would be Katsuki in this situation.

If it hadn't been for Deku, Katsuki could be dead already.

Even if he didn't want to admit it, Katsuki couldn't ignore it. He couldn't pretend that it never happened. He hated that he was had been weak to the point of needing someone as *Deku* to save his ass, but it had happened anyway, and there was nothing he could do about it. The least he could do to repay Deku – to *not* be in debt with him – was to fucking prevent

him from dying. And if those fucktards at UA failed to save the nerd's life… Katsuki would take the matter into his own hands.

He knew Todoroki was right. No one had told him anything because everyone knew Katsuki would dive headfirst into danger if that meant he would have a chance to save Deku. Because they knew Katsuki, they knew of his explosive temperament, they knew he hated owing people things. They probably thought he would grasp the first opportunity he found to get rid of Deku's soul, too.

What they didn't know was that Katsuki wanted to help Deku because… Well, because…

Fuck. He still couldn't admit it, could he?

He didn't hate Deku. Not anymore, at least. Having someone glued to you for so long, sharing your feelings and feeling the other person's emotions for so long… There was no way Katsuki could keep hating Deku's guts when he could *feel* what the nerd was feeling. When he could *feel* that the nerd was actually sincere about his admiration for Katsuki, when he could *feel* the nerd didn't look down on him as he had always thought, when he could *feel* the utter pain the nerd felt whenever Katsuki directed his rage towards him. Katsuki found himself surprised to realize that he didn't want Deku to stop being in pain just because he could feel his pain as well (otherwise, he wouldn't have sparred with him). He wanted Deku to stop being in pain because a part of him, a small part that had been hidden and buried beneath layers and layers of years-long anger, was empathetic enough – or became empathetic enough – to actually… To actually give a shit about Deku.

Maybe it had been the memories. Remembering how Deku had saved him, and how distraught he had felt when he thought Deku was dead… That did something to Katsuki. He couldn't completely understand why he had freaked out so hard at the prospect of the nerd dying, but it had upset him. It had driven him *crazy*.

He remembered punching nurses, shouting, screaming, wailing at the top of his lungs, he remembered wanting to explode the place, to explode the villain, to explode whatever he could touch, he remembered the rage, and the anger, and the fury, and the pain, and the loss. He remembered the way Deku's dead body lay askew on the floor, he remembered the way his empty eyes had stared at him, he remembered how Deku's last breath was wasted on shouting his name, how Deku's last energy was put into saving Katsuki's life. A person who hated him, who despised him, who mistreated him his whole life. And yeah, maybe Deku had hit his head as a baby for him to end up caring so much about someone as Katsuki, but he cared anyway, no matter how hard Katsuki tried to drive him away, and he had given *his life* for Katsuki's. There was *no way* Katsuki could keep hating him after that. He wasn't a fucking monster, after all.

That didn't mean he knew how to show Deku that, or that he wanted to. That didn't even mean he knew what he was feeling in the first place. He didn't want to appear weak. He didn't want Deku to think he was getting soft, or that he was an emotional prick, or that he was *anything* other than himself. He didn't know why he didn't want Deku to know… He just didn't.

Funny how Katsuki never gave a single shit about other people's opinions in his life, but now Deku finding out about his feelings terrified him.

But what feelings were these? Ok, he didn't hate Deku anymore, great fucking improvement, yadda yadda yadda. Now that he didn't hate him, what did he *feel*?

Annoyance, that was for sure. Deku drove him fucking crazy. But also… Katsuki realized he couldn't imagine a life without him. Deku had always been there, ever since he could remember, calling him Kacchan with his stupid fucking voice and chasing after him with his stupid fucking admiration. He remembered the drawings and the photos and felt guilt twist his chest. Deku had always been there… He had always been a constant in his life. Even when Katsuki ignored him, he had always been there to wish him a good morning. Even when Katsuki mistreated him, he had always been there to praise him. Even when Katsuki told him off, he had always chased behind him. Even when Katsuki called him a quirkless loser and told him to kill himself… He… He…

Katsuki sighed. He had a lot of things to make up for, apparently.

He wished he knew how to say 'I'm sorry'. His life would be a lot easier if he did.

He got so lost in thought that he only remembered the conversation he was having with All Might when the man answered his question.

"That is not an option, shonen", All Might said reassuringly, offering them his trademark smile (even though he was in his bony form) and giving them a thumbs up that felt way too forced for Katsuki's liking. "We will find the villain and restore Young Midoriya to his body. Everything will be fine".

Katsuki stared up at him, incredulity written all over his face. Izuku stared up at All Might with admiration.

"Just tell his mom the truth", Katsuki said, turning on his heels and starting to walk away. "The whole truth; not the half-one you told me. She deserves to know".

All Might didn't respond, but even if he had, Katsuki wouldn't have heard it anyway. He headed to the dining hall in order to grab himself lunch before the afternoon classes began.

"You look upset".

"I'm ok".

“I don’t know if you’re really that dumb or if you just like pissing me off. We can *share feelings*, dickhead. I *know* you’re not ok”.

“What is it to you anyway, Kacchan?”

Katsuki turned his head to stare at Izuku, a frown coloring his brow. *Someone* was being sassy. Still, the response was so unlike Deku that he felt even more curious about the reasons behind his sour mood. What could Katsuki have possibly done to piss him off so much? He didn’t remember anything.

“Was it because I swore in front of All Might?”

“*What*? No”.

“Hm. Was it because I told him your mom looked ugly?”

“That wasn’t really nice”.

“I didn’t mean she *is* ugly, I meant she *looked* ugly because she was clearly spending all her time worrying about your sorry ass. No one looks pretty after losing days of sleep”.

“That wasn’t it, Kacchan”.

“Will you tell me what was it, or do you plan on making me keep guessing?”

“It’s… Nothing. It’s not a big deal”.

“You’re looking at me as if I personally killed your pet puppy with my bare hands”.

“No, I’m not”.

“Fine. You’re looking at me as if I called your mom ugly”.

“You did”.

“So that’s it?”

“No”.

“*Fuck*. Then just *tell me* already. I don’t have the patience to deal with this”.

“Then don’t. I’m not asking you to and it’s not a big deal”.

“But you’re being all sour and miserable and *sassy* and it’s pissing me the fuck off”.

“I’ve been meaning to talk to you about that. I think we can’t keep doing this feeling-exchanging thing for much longer. I think it’s tiring us out”.

“Well, of fucking *course* it’s tiring us out, genius. But do you have any plans on how to keep your sappy feelings to yourself before they end up being in me?”

Izuku sighed.

“Sorry. I didn’t mean to”.

“Yeah. Just fucking tell me what’s wrong so we can fix it”.

A pause.

“I don’t think it’s something that can be fixed”.

“For *fuck’s sake*”, Katsuki let out a prolonged sigh and a groan. “Why did I have to end up stuck with the most melodramatic asshole in this entire school?”

Izuku didn’t respond, bowing his head instead.

“Look, I told you I don’t have the patience to deal with this kind of shit. I’m not going to keep insisting on it. If you want to tell me, you tell me. If you don’t, then it’s your problem. I’m not begging you for shit”.

With that, he started to eat his lunch. Luckily, the dining hall was almost empty, so Katsuki didn’t really have to worry about looking like a lunatic while he spoke to Deku. Deku, on the other hand, fell silent.

Katsuki quickly ate his meal. He was thankful for Deku finally being silent for once in his life – how many times had he prayed for that to happen? – but, at the same time, the amount of silence wasn’t uncanny. Katsuki didn’t want to seem ungrateful, because he spent most of his time telling Deku to shut up, but *fuck*, a Deku that didn’t start conversation, that didn’t blabber at him, that didn’t mumble and mutter and talk to himself? That shit was uncanny. It was pissing him off. It was driving him *mad*.

“So you’re not telling me what the fuck is wrong, right?”, Katsuki asked angrily once he was done eating, slamming one of his fists on the table and glaring at Deku. Deku stared up at him with sad eyes and sighed, shaking his head.

“It’s nothing. It’ll be over soon”, he shrugged simply. For some reason, in that moment, he reminded Katsuki of the skinny, shy, cowardly boy that only wore black and that walked around with his head low back at school. He scoffed.

“Whatever”, he spat simply before standing up and heading out of the hall. Izuku followed him closely, but still silently. Katsuki snarled.

It really pissed him off when Deku did that. Why couldn’t he just tell Katsuki what was getting him so riled up? Did he not trust Katsuki? Or did he just do it for the dramatics of it? Why the fuck couldn’t Deku just grab him by the shoulders and scream what he was thinking at him instead of playing this stupid fucking game? Katsuki had no fucking patience for it.

If Deku wanted to be like that, then *fine*. Katsuki wouldn’t play into his little stupid game.

They watched the afternoon classes and Izuku didn’t ask him any questions and, *ok*, that was weird as fuck. Whatever was making Deku so upset must be really serious for him not to ask

one single thing at Katsuki's ear during a lecture. As they walked out of the classroom, Katsuki promptly ignoring Kaminari's question if he would be able to make it to Kirishima's party, he nudged Deku's arm with his elbow, a bit more roughly than necessary. He hated that he was the one bending the knee, but Izuku's sad mood was making *him* sad.

"Is it because of what All Might said?"

Izuku thought for a moment.

"I mean, that upset me a bit, but… No, that's not it. Just leave it, Kacchan", he added with a sigh.

"Oh, so when it's with *you*, you can keep sticking your ugly nose in my business and refuse to drop things, but when it's with *me*, I have to leave it? Fuck off", he scoffed. "Is it because of your mom not knowing?"

"*No*, Kacchan", Izuku sighed.

"You're starting to piss me off. Is it because I sparred with you?"

"No. That was actually nice, to be honest".

"Weirdo".

A pause of realization.

"Is it because I call you names?"

A sigh.

"I've grown used to that already".

"Hm. Is it because I tried to attack Icy Hot?"

Izuku blushed, remembering the way he needed to hold back a half-naked Kacchan to prevent him from jumping at Todoroki.

"No".

"But it has to do with Icy Hot, right?", Katsuki scoffed. "Your face is all red and shit".

"No, it's *not*!"

"Yes, it is. Do you have the hots for him or some shit? Is that it?"

Izuku snapped his head towards Kacchan, a horrified look on his face, which had become really pale really fast. Katsuki stared back with a bored expression.

"*W-W-What*?!"

“Oh, come *on*. He was the one who visited you the most before the old lady locked him out. He’s willing to risk his damn chance at becoming a hero just because of your stupid ass. *And* you get all stutter-y and flush-y like some sort of fairy tale princess whenever he’s around or someone mentions him”, Katsuki rolled his eyes. “I’m not stupid”.

Izuku decided on that moment that Katsuki was, indeed, stupid.

“I – I don’t have – I don’t – I mean – T-Todoroki-kun is – he’s – I –“, Izuku stuttered, incapable of formulating a coherent sentence. How could Kacchan *think* that?!

“Deep breaths, Deku. If you faint because of Icy Hot, I’m not dragging your ass along”, he said with forced indifference, not looking at Izuku and putting a glare on his face. Izuku’s flush deepened.

“It’s *not him*!”, Izuku protested, his voice coming out louder and more high pitched than he had intended. He took a deep breath and tried to regain his composure before continuing, even if Katsuki wasn’t even looking at his general direction while they walked. “It’s not. Him, I mean. I – we – we don’t have anything. I d-don’t – I don’t have t-the *hots* for him, or whatever it is you’re thinking!”

“I don’t give a shit who you have the hots for, nerd”, Katsuki said stoically. “I just want to know why you’re so upset. Is it because I tried to attack him or not?”

“*No*”, Izuku responded vehemently.

“But does it have to do with him?”

“No”, Izuku sighed. “I mean, yes. I don’t *know*”, he huffed in frustration.

I, for one, know Midoriya’s life is worth the risk.

Todoroki thought he was worth the risk. Kacchan didn’t. So, in a way, it *had* to do with Todoroki, but not in the way Kacchan was thinking. It was the *opposite* of what Kacchan was thinking. Kacchan, however, was too oblivious to realize that Izuku’s nervousness had *nothing* to do with the Half-and-Half boy.

“Pff. Whatever”, Katsuki scoffed. “If you want to get into his pants or some crap like that, wait until you’re back in your body. This is the kind of shit that I’m not doing for you, even if you paid me actual money. Though I’m sure you won’t be able to handle it on your own”, he added with a scowl.

“Kacchan”, Izuku groaned with frustration. “I don’t like Todoroki-kun like that”.

“I don’t give a shit who you like”.

Izuku sighed and lowered his head. He decided it would be useless to get into that discussion with Kacchan, and all the possible results to that conversation seemed more disastrous to Izuku than anything.

Izuku was still having a hard time figuring out what exactly were his feelings for Kacchan, but he knew for a fact that he was surprisingly adamant on not wanting Kacchan to think he had *any* sort of romantic interest in Todoroki. He and Todoroki were good friends, and Izuku loved him, but… He had never looked at Todoroki like *that*. He had never *thought* of Todoroki like that. Actually, he had never thought of anyone like that! Maybe Uraraka, but… it was different. She was the first girl Izuku ever spoke to, so that had to cause some impact, right? He couldn't imagine his life without either Uraraka or Todoroki, but it was *different*.

Kacchan had been there with him since the beginning. Despite the bullying, the hurting, and the distance that grew between them, he had *always* been there. He was a constant. Losing Kacchan would be like losing a limb. Losing Kacchan would be like – like losing a part of himself. After all, for better or for worse, Kacchan was the reason why Izuku was who he was. He had *made* who Izuku was.

They arrived at the bedroom, which was still a mess after their sparring session. Katsuki tidied it up and Izuku wanted to help, but he couldn't – his hands would just phase through things. Instead, he simply stayed out of Kacchan's way and watched silently as he set his belongings back into place. Once he was done, he stripped out of his uniform and changed clothes right there, in the middle of the bedroom, pointing Izuku with a tired glare.

"Next time, let's take the sparring to the gym", he said conversationally. Izuku was still a bit upset at Kacchan, but decided it would be for the better to engage in that conversation.

"Won't you be embarrassed to have people see you fighting against thin air?", he asked with curiosity. Katsuki huffed out a breath and sat heavily on his rolling chair.

"I don't feel embarrassed about *anything*, Deku. Didn't I tell you I don't give a shit what other people think of me?"

"Oh, right", Izuku lowered his head. Katsuki turned his laptop on and grabbed some of his notebooks from inside his backpack, setting them on his desk. Looking above his shoulder, Katsuki realized Izuku was still unmoving at the same spot, head bowed, and rolled his eyes.

"So are you coming or what?", he asked with annoyance.

"Hm?", Izuku asked, confused by Katsuki's invitation. Katsuki turned his chair so that he could properly face Izuku.

"I still don't know what the fuck you're so upset for, but I told you two days ago that I'd explain the stuff you didn't understand from Aizawa sensei's lecture. So are you getting your ass over here? Or will you just stand there like a fucking statue?", he said in a neutral tone. Izuku stared at him with wide eyes. "You told me to be clearer next time I offered a favor, so there you go, clear as a day", he added without missing a beat.

"A-Are – Are you serious, Kacchan?", he asked, surprised by the offer. Izuku had though Kacchan had only been joking when he made the offer, but if he was being serious – that was an opportunity Izuku couldn't throw away. He approached the studying desk and sat on the edge of the bed beside it, from where he could see Kacchan's notebooks and laptop without difficulty.

“Yeah, I’m fucking serious. There’s no use beating you if you’re dumb and useless. We gotta be at the same rank for my victory to mean something”, Katsuki responded, but something about his tone – something about his eyes – told Izuku that wasn’t the only reason why he was teaching him. Maybe he was trying to make Izuku feel better? Maybe he was trying to make up for him being upset, even though he didn’t know the cause behind Izuku’s sadness? Or maybe he just wanted Izuku to stop asking so many questions during the lecture? Maybe he was rewarding Izuku for being quiet? Maybe he had enjoyed the silence? There were so many thoughts and theories crossing Izuku’s mind that he couldn’t concentrate on what Kacchan was saying. All he could do was stare at Kacchan’s face, take in Kacchan’s eyes, and watch, dazed, as Kacchan’s lips moved while he talked about Aizawa sensei’s lecture and their studies.

He needed to concentrate. Kacchan was taking time to give him a private lesson, and he was one of the best in their class, so Izuku needed to take the most of it… He couldn’t afford to be distracted. Kacchan wouldn’t ever let him get away with it if he didn’t pay enough attention. He shook the distracting thoughts about Kacchan’s reasons from his head and focused on what Kacchan was saying, rather than how his lips were moving. He managed to get five good minutes of unfaltering concentration, until…

“Ah, *fuck*. Kirishima’s handwriting sucks. Move aside, nerd; let met me grab my reading glasses”.

And he put on his reading glasses.

Yeah. Izuku had it bad.

He had it *so bad*.

From: Dunce Face

Hey man, you know if you can make it to the party already?

From: Dunce Face

I was kidding when I said I was kidding about you not having to cook

From: Dunce Face

You know how helpless we are. Can you please cook for us???

From: Dunce Face

Pleeeeeeeeaaaaaaaaseeeeeeeeee

From: Dunce Face

No one's as good at it as you!!!

From: Dunce Face

Also Eijirou will be so sad if you don't go :-/

From: Dunce Face

Ok, ok. Cooking is not required but it would be greatly appreciated

From: Dunce Face

Can you do it???????

From: Raccoon Eyes

It's shady to turn off your last seen AND your read receipts feature, Bakubro

From: Raccoon Eyes

What are you hiding???

From: Raccoon Eyes

Anyway don't listen to Kami if he bothers you about the cooking, we just want you to come over and hang with us <3

From: Tape Guy

Hey man can I borrow some of your notes for aizawa's last lecture

From: Tape Guy

I really need them man

From: Tape Guy

Can I come over??

From: Tape Guy

:c

From: Shitty Hair

Hey babe let me know when I can stop by to lend you those notes you asked for!

From: Shitty Hair

And when we can talk about your bakufeelings ;-)

From: Shitty Hair

Ok no more jokes I promise

From: Shitty Hair

You can really talk to me ok

From: Bakubro

Don’t fucking call me babe

From: Shitty Hair

Cranky

From: Bakubro

Also forget about the feelings shit

From Bakubro:

I don’t wanna talk about it anymore

From: Shitty Hair

Why not??

From: Shitty Hair

I’m coming over

From: Bakubro

No

From: Bakubro

Not now

From: Bakubro

I’m busy

From: Shitty Hair

You’re busy even for me? :(

From: Bakubro

Uh, yeah??

From: Bakubro

Also when you come over don’t talk about the feelings shit

From: Bakubro

Let’s just talk about it over text ok

From: Bakubro

WHEN I want to

From: Bakubro

Not right now

From: Shitty Hair

Why not??

From: Shitty Hair

Oh

From: Shitty Hair

Oh my god

From: Shitty Hair

Is this about Midoriya

From: Shitty Hair

Is the rare-feeling confusion thing about Midoriya??

From: Bakubro

Fuck off

From: Shitty Hair

OH MY GOD

From: Shitty Hair

IT IS

From: Shitty Hair

OH MY GOD WHAT'S HAPPENING

From: Shitty Hair

I'M COMING OVER RN

From: Bakubro

Kirishima. I swear to fuckign god. If you open your damn trap about this shit inside my bedroom in front of Deku. You will no longer have teeth by the morning. Because I'll tear them all out. I'll tear them out using my fists. And I won't even use my quirk. It'll be raw strength. I'll tear them all out and I'll make you swallow them, one by one.

From: Bakubro

If you open your mouth to talk about feelings in front of Deku you won't ever see the light of the day again

From: Shitty Hair

Message noted

From: Bakubro

Also don't come over now I'm busy

From: Shitty Hair

You're not going to tell me what with? :(

From: Bakubro

No because it's none of your damn business

From: Shitty Hair

:(

From: Shitty Hair

You're making me curious

From: Bakubro

I don’t give a shit

From: Bakubro

I’ll text you when you can come over

From: Bakubro

Bye

From: Shitty Hair

Bakugouuuuu we talked about just saying bye

From: Raccoon Eyes

We can all see you replying to Kiri’s texts but not to ours

From: Racoon Eyes

That’s favoritism you know

From: Racoon Eyes

And also mean

Read at 19:02

From: Racoon Eyes

Did you turn the read receipts back on just to piss me off

From: Raccoon Eyes

Did you turn it off again

From: Raccoon Eyes

Is this your messed up way of communicating with me

Read at 19:08

From: Raccoon Eyes

Cool it’s like using a ouija board

From: Raccoon Eyes

You’re scarier than the spirits tho

From: Raccoon Eyes

Wish we could talk to Midoriya like this instead of having to use YOU as a board

From: Bakubro

Die

From: Raccoon Eyes

Ah there he is ^-^

“You got it or not, nerd?”, he raised an eyebrow at Deku, who promptly nodded his head, making his curls bounce up and down and fall all over his eyes. Katsuki rolled his eyes. “Good. Because I’m not teaching you again”, he huffed, closing his notebooks and putting them away inside his drawer. Izuku frowned at him.

“Why not?”, he asked, sounding genuinely curious.

“I don’t have the patience to be a teacher”, Katsuki shrugged simply. “If you have any more doubts, save them for when you’re back in your body”.

“Well, I think you’re really good at teaching”, Izuku shrugged.

“Good for you, I guess”, Katsuki said simply, standing up from his rolling chair and grabbing his phone. Despite of his harsh words, Izuku could tell Katsuki had only said them out of habit. With each passing day, he was getting better at telling the difference from when Kacchan was just teasing and from when he was actually being serious.

“Are you – uh”, Izuku hesitated, following Katsuki with his eyes but not standing up from the bed. “Are you texting Kirishima-kun again?”

“What is it to you?”, Katsuki scoffed without looking at Izuku while he typed. Izuku blushed and turned his head away.

“N-Nothing. I was just thinking, uh –“, he tried to make up a viable reason. If he was honest with himself, he was actually feeling curious about what Kirishima and Kacchan talked about so much, since the boy never replied to *any* of his other friends’ texts, but Izuku couldn’t just *tell him* that. “Kaminari-kun and Mina-san said something about a birthday party earlier”, Izuku shrugged.

“Yeah”, Katsuki responded with indifference while he continued to type on his phone, telling Kirishima he could come over. “It’s Shitty Hair’s birthday next week. They want to throw him a surprise party or whatever”.

“Oh”, Izuku said simply, lowering his head. “And you’re going, right?”

Katsuki scoffed and sent Izuku a quick condescending glimpse.

“Of course I’m fucking going. I just like to piss them off and pretend I’m not interested”, he shrugged.

Izuku decided to stay silent after that.

Katsuki resumed typing down on his phone and placed it back into his pocket, turning around to face Izuku.

“Well, Shitty Hair will be over any minute now, so I’ll wait for him outside”, he announced.

“What? Why?”, Izuku snapped his head towards Katsuki and frowned, the sudden movement making his curls bounce over the top of his eyes again. Izuku swapped them away with an annoyed gesture. “I – I mean… Why not invite him in?”

Katsuki squinted his eyes at Izuku for a moment. He couldn’t just say ‘I don’t want to risk Shitty Hair running his mouth and spilling something about the feelings-talk I wanted to have with him in front of you, because you’re a nosy fucking nerd who has no boundaries and you’ll keep bothering me about it if you overhear it and I won’t know what to answer to make you shut up because I have no fucking idea what I’m feeling in the first place’, so instead he said:

“Too many people in my bedroom for one day. I don’t like this invasion of privacy”.

Izuku stared at him with a look that told Katsuki he didn’t believe him.

“If you listen to my conversation through the door”, Katsuki pointed a serious finger at him. “I’ll cut both your ears off”.

“What’s there to listen?”, Izuku shrugged, feigning innocence. Katsuki could see some hidden knowledge behind Izuku’s eyes. Was the nerd onto him…?

“Nothing that’s any of your business, so you better stay the fuck out of it”, Katsuki scoffed, rolling his eyes and walking back towards Deku. “Also, you need to fucking do something about that”.

“About what?”, Izuku frowned.

“Your shitty hair”, Katsuki said, searching his drawers for something without looking at Izuku. “It’s getting fucking ridiculous”.

“Well, it’s bothering me too, Kacchan”, Izuku said tiredly. “It falls over my eyes all the time and it tickles my neck”.

“The old lady doesn’t want me to give you the cooties by breathing the same air as you, so I can’t give you my amazing haircut”, he shrugged, finally finding what he was looking for and smirking triumphantly. He held up a headband at Deku, waving it at him. “Since the scissors just phase through your shitty soul’s hair, this will have to do for now”, he said, throwing the headband at Izuku.

Izuku raised his hands to grab it, but the headband phased right through him and plopped against the wall directly behind him. Both boys frowned.

“I don’t think this will work”, Izuku commented.

“Shit”, Katsuki said, grabbing the headband from the bed and staring at it as if it had personally offended him. “I thought this crap would’ve worked. What if I try to put this on you?”

“I don’t know if it will stay in my head”, Izuku admitted. “Maybe it will just fall off after you let go of it”.

“Shut up and sit still”, Katsuki instructed sternly, placing the headband around Deku’s head and pushing it all the way up to his forehead so that his curls were hidden beneath it and held securely into place. However, as soon as Katsuki let go of the material, the headband phased right through Izuku and fell to the bed again. “Fuck”, Katsuki huffed with annoyance, placing his hands at his hips and staring at Izuku as if he was trying to find a solution for his hair problem.

“It’s ok”, Izuku shrugged. “I’ll just keep pushing them away”.

“You look like a homeless dog”, Katsuki said without missing a beat. “I won’t walk around with you looking like this”.

“No one else can see me, Kacchan”, Izuku pointed out with a tiny chuckle.

“*I* can see you, and that amount of fucking hair is pissing me off. It’s like you have a bush growing on your damn head”.

“Kacchan!”, Izuku protested, but there was slight humor in his voice.

“Ugh, whatever. Just stay there”, Katsuki instructed in the same annoyed tone as before. “I’ll grab the notes from Kirishima and then we can figure out what to do about your shitty nest of a hair”.

“Ok”, Izuku said in agreement, but he didn’t think Kacchan heard it before he walked out of the bedroom and closed the door behind him.

Izuku sighed and allowed himself to fall down on the bed, combing his fingers through his hair and then throwing his arms above his head while he stared at the ceiling.

He liked Kacchan. He liked Kacchan *a lot*. He wished they could be actual friends for once. He wished… He wished they could actually be *close* to each other without needing to be forced together by a villain's quirk. He wished they could have this – hanging out together, talking to each other, sparring friendly, having studying sessions – because they wanted to, and not because they had no other choice.

Izuku wished they could have this. He wasn't so sure *Kacchan* did. He didn't really need Izuku, after all… Not when he had amazing friends like Mina, and Kaminari, and Sero. Not when he had someone like Kirishima… Not when he had friends.

The truth was: Kacchan never needed him. Izuku was the one who had always needed Kacchan. He had needed Kacchan as a friend, he had needed Kacchan as an outlet after he found out he was quirkless, he had needed Kacchan as his personal image of victory.

Kacchan, on the other hand? He didn't need Izuku. Izuku could probably disappear in front of his very eyes, he could slip away through his very fingers, and, at the end of the day, it wouldn't make any difference to Kacchan.

It would probably mean nothing at all to him.

Izuku felt tired.

"Here you go, man", Kirishima handed him the notebook, standing in front of him in the hallway. "Though I think you've already caught up with it in today's lecture. Still, it's all in there, even if Yao-Momo didn't help me this time", he shrugged.

"Fine. I'll give it back later", Katsuki said, ready to twist his doorknob and walk back into his room unceremoniously.

"Hey, wait!", Kirishima called after him, holding one of Katsuki's wrists. "Why are we talking in the hallway anyway, man?", he asked, suspicion and confusion written all over his face. Katsuki glared at him and leaned in closer to his friend.

"Because I don't want to risk you running your damn mouth in front of the shitty nerd", Katsuki hissed at Kirishima, whose eyes widened at the words.

“Ok, man… What’s really going on here?”, he asked, sounding interested. “I mean… I have no clue and you’re being all secretive about it. Did something happen between you and Midoriya? What *is* it?”

Katsuki sighed heavily, checking the hallway on either side to see if there was someone listening to their conversation, before grabbing Kirishima’s forearm and dragging him slightly away from his bedroom door. Once they were at a safe distance, Katsuki gave Kirishima a tired look.

“I don’t actually hate him”, Katsuki told his friend, looking as serious as ever. Kirishima blinked blankly at him.

“O…kay?”, he frowned.

“Don’t give me that fucking look. I’ve hated him all my life”, Katsuki shook his head. “And now I don’t hate him anymore”.

“I think… that’s… good?”, Kirishima tried tentatively. He looked extremely confused. “I mean, it’s good *not* to hate people, especially if you’re in the hero business”.

“Yeah, but why don’t I hate him anymore?”, Katsuki asked, his voice barely above a whisper. Kirishima frowned again. “We’ve known each other since we were kids, and I’ve *always* hated him, ever since I can remember. I couldn’t tell why, and I always thought it was because he was a quirkless loser who thought he could stand up to people even though he had no idea how to defend himself, but now…”, he shook his head. “I don’t think I hate him anymore. He annoys the fuck out of me, but…”, he trailed off, sighing.

“Dude”, Kirishima told him, staring at Katsuki as if he was a confused child trying to understand things that were bigger than him. “You’ve been spending more time together. Actually, you’ve been spending *all* the time together. It’s only natural you… grow on him, you know?”, he shrugged.

“*No*”, Katsuki shook his head firmly, glaring at Kirishima. “I don’t fucking know”.

“Look”, Kirishima said patiently, placing a hand on Katsuki’s shoulder. He didn’t shrug away from the touch. “I know you suck at this because you barely spend any time with other people, but this has happened to you before. Even if you don’t like to admit it, you’re friends with me, and Mina, and Kami, and Sero. It didn’t happen out of nowhere. It took you time to blossom into the beautiful, manly bakuflower you are now – sorry, sorry”, he added with a nervous chuckle when Katsuki snarled at him. “What I mean is that it took *time* for you to grow on us. You spent time with us, and we hung out, and now we’re friends. Maybe you thought you hated Midoriya because you never got to spend as much time with him before?”

“Nerd was glued to me all the time when we were growing up”, Katsuki explained, crossing his arms above his chest and looking grumpily at the distance. “He never stopped following me around. That asshole spent 11 years glued to me”, he scoffed. “We spent a lot of fucking time together, so why is this only happening *now*?”

Kirishima seemed to think for a while, his eyes looking lost as he took in what Katsuki was telling him.

“I don’t know, man”, he shrugged. “You said he followed you around and he was the one glued to you. Sounds to me like all the effort was coming from Midoriya”.

“Yeah, because I just wanted him to *leave me the fuck alone* and he never listened”, Katsuki scoffed. “As usual”.

“Yeah”, Kirishima nodded emphatically, as if Katsuki was following the precise train of thought he wanted him to. “But – like, you also never listened to him, right?”

“*Huh*?”, Katsuki frowned.

“When he talked to you, and tried to be your friend or whatever – you never paid attention to him, right? You just told him off?”

“Yeah”, Katsuki repeated emphatically, annoyed. “Because I didn’t want to be his fucking friend”.

“So back then, you could tell him off, and even though he kept following you around, you had the option to ignore him, right?”

Katsuki squinted his eyes at Kirishima.

“Now you can’t do that”, Kirishima pointed out triumphantly. “Because not only is he literally incapable of *not* following you, but you can also feel what he’s feeling!”

Katsuki scowled.

“Ahh, Bakubro! You’re bonding with him!”, Kirishima exclaimed triumphantly, tapping one hand to Katsuki’s shoulder, even though his voice was low to maintain discretion.

“Shut the *fuck* up”, Katsuki growled, swatting Kirishima’s hand away angrily. “I’m not!”

“Yes, you *are*! You don’t hate him anymore because you’ve made an empathic bond with him! And you know what that means, right?”

“No, and I don’t want to fucking know –“

“You like him because he likes you!”

“*What*?”

“Well, actually, I’m not so sure about that. But it made sense to me, you know?”

“Just to you. It doesn’t make any fucking sense to *me*”, Katsuki scoffed.

“But, like. If when you were growing up, you acted the same way as you act today… Then I gotta admit Midoriya is manlier than I thought”.

“What the fuck; *why*?”

“Because despite of the treatment you gave him, he stuck around! He must like you a lot to have stayed”.

“Or maybe he’s messed up in the head”.

“Or *maybe* he just really admires you and wants really hard to be your friend. I don’t see what’s so wrong in trying to be his friend, too. That’s what you’re doing, right?”

“*What*?”

“Oh, come *on*, man. We all see you two talking to each other all the time! And no: no one judges you for that”.

“I don’t give a single fuck if you guys do”, Katsuki added quickly.

“Yes, yes, I *know*”, Kirishima sighed tiredly. “But what I mean is – I don’t know, man. I think it’s nice you two are finally getting along”.

“We’re not *getting along*”, Katsuki growled. “I said I don’t hate him anymore; I didn’t say I love him”.

“I didn’t say you love him, either”, Kirishima gave him a surprised look, blinking blankly and frowning. If life was a cartoon, fume would have come out of Katsuki’s ears and nostrils.

“*Whatever*. My point is that I tolerate him a bit more now, but that doesn’t mean we’re fucking *getting along* or whatever the hell it is you’re trying to insinuate”, he barked angrily.

“If you’re so sure about that, then why did you want to talk to me about this?”, Kirishima frowned, confusion and curiosity etched in his face.

“I fucking *didn’t*! I changed my mind the moment I sent you that fucking text, but you kept pissing me off about it!”, Katsuki growled. “So *there*. I don’t actually hate Deku. Is that good enough for you? Can you fucking drop the subject now and leave me the fuck alone?!”, he huffed out, sounding way angrier than he needed to be. He sounded almost… defensive. Kirishima raised his hands at him in a gesture that indicated he meant no harm.

“Ok, man”, he said in surrender. “Ok. I get it. That’s good. That’s good”, he gave Katsuki a tentative smile, trying to calm his friend down.

“*Good*. Now *stop* talking about that”, Katsuki scoffed, letting go of Kirishima and turning back towards his door.

“Ok”, Kirishima nodded, his hands still raised. “Ok. Cool”.

“I’ll give your fucking notebook back when I’m done with it”, Katsuki announced, still sounding angry.

“That’s cool, man. Take all the time you need”, Kirishima added patiently.

“Now fuck off”, Katsuki growled in conclusion. Kirishima nodded, taking one step back.

“You sure you’re fine? You don’t want me to come in with you?”, he asked friendly.

“Yes, I’m fucking *fine*”, Katsuki barked in response, not sounding fine at all.

“I’m just asking because your doorknob is about to blow up”, Kirishima pointed at where Katsuki was gripping the doorknob with one hot, incandescent hand.

“*Fuck*”, Katsuki muttered under his breath, removing his hand from the doorknob before it could actually blow up and letting out a series of curses. Kirishima took the distraction to take more steps back.

“Just text me if you need anything, ok?”, Kirishima told him from a safe distance. “And try not to blow my notebook up!”

Katsuki didn’t bother to respond as he tried his best to twist the doorknob without making it melt of fall apart. Damn fucking Deku making him fuck stuff up with his quirk because of fucking confused feelings. Couldn’t he just figure out what to feel for once? How did Deku fucking manage being happy and sad at the same fucking time? Why couldn’t he just *pick one*? No wonder they were both always feeling so exhausted. Deku was a lot to deal with. A whole fucking lot.

With Katsuki, things were way easier and more objective. He had no idea how stupid Deku was making him feel, so he chose the simpler option: he didn’t hate Deku. There. Problem fucking *solved*. Now he didn’t have to waste any more time on trying to figure his emotions out or fucking cry like a loser because of overwhelming feelings. Cutting problems short and solving them objectively was so much simpler than stressing out over them.

He was cool with feeling not-hate for Deku, whatever the hell that meant. For Katsuki, feeling not-hate was good enough for the time being.

Chapter End Notes

So, here it is! Is Kacchan jealous of Todoroki? Is Deku jealous of Kirishima? You tell me!
Also, I gotta let you guys know that, unfortunately, my vacations are over today, so I'm getting back to work tomorrow! This means updates won't be so regular anymore, and the time between updates will probably be a little longer because I'll have less time to write :-(
Either way, I can assure you guys I won't abandon this work or leave it on hiatus! I love writing this story and I hope you guys enjoy reading it as much as I enjoy writing it.
I feel like the ending of this chapter got a bit too rushed, but I just wanted to update it already before I had to leave to work! I hope you guys like it!
See you next time, hopefully soon!

Also, just a quick disclaimer! I read and love all of your guys' comments! They make me happy beyond words and they're definitely my favorite part about writing! Fanfiction doesn't really pay off in my case, so I see the comments and kudos as my "reward"! And trust me: it's an spectacular reward!
I've only gotten to replying to the comments more recently, but I can't always reply to all of them :-(I didn't reply to the ones in chapter 9 because I was focused on writing and publishing this one! And now I feel a bit awkward to just go back and reply to everything (because I haven't even replied to any of the comments in the previous chapters either, except for chapter 8). Anyway, I hope you guys don't get upset at me if I didn't reply to your comment! I'm not ignoring you, I'm probably just busy working on the new chapter or feeling too socially awkward to do so! Either way, I always read through every single comment you guys make and I love them with all my heart, however big or small they may be! Thank you guys for taking the time to read this story and for leaving your feedback! You're the best!

Chapter 11: Mighto Mighto!

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Missed call at 9:00 from: Unknown

Missed call at 9:04 from: Unknown

Missed call at 10:30 from: Unknown

From: Unknown

Hello… I hope I have the right number… I just wanted to thank you for talking to All Might on my behalf… He came over earlier this morning and told me what is really going on with my Izuku... Of course I was not pleased by all the lies and secrets but at least I'm glad I'm no longer in the dark... Would you like to come over later? I can cook you something nice as a proper thank you for intervening.

From: Unknown

It's Izuku's mother, Inko Midoriya… In case you don't have my number.

From: Deku's Mom

I tried calling you, but I suppose it was too early… Let me know if you can come by later.

Katsuki frowned and rubbed the sleep away from his eyes, annoyed. First, because he had slept way more than he had planned to – it was fucking 11 a.m., for fucks sake, and he usually woke up at 5 –; second, because why the *fuck* did moms feel the need to text so ominously? Couldn't this woman just use normal punctuation?

He set the phone aside and shifted on the bed, stretching – and emitting a little grunt in the process – and staring up at the ceiling. He was still feeling tired and sleepy and, leaning his weight in one elbow, he looked over the pillow fort separating his side of the bed from Deku's. Katsuki found the boy was still fast asleep, lying on a fetal position with his back turned to him. His mess of a hair was sticking out in all directions, blocking his stupid freckled face away from Katsuki's view.

Deku hadn't said a word to Katsuki after he reentered the room on the night before, even as he spat curses and angry swears at the fact his doorknob had half-melted. He would have to request for a new one *again*, and he definitely wasn't in the mood for that sort of bureaucracy. Deku had simply listened to his angry yelling, without meeting Katsuki's eyes and bearing that sickening kicked-puppy look on his face.

Then Katsuki had announced he was going to study some more by himself, now that Deku had already cleared away all his doubts, and Deku had just nodded at him, still avoiding his eyes, still refusing to speak up. He had made his way over to his side of the bed and lied down, his back turned to Katsuki and his hair hiding his face from view, exactly in the way it was still doing now. And he had fallen asleep in the matter of seconds without a single word.

Or… sort of. Katsuki, who had kept sending subtle glimpses towards Deku every other minute, couldn't tell for sure whether he was actually asleep or just pretending.

(As he stared at shitty Deku's back, he still couldn't tell, but the thought that Deku could be hypothetically tricking him made him want to punch a hole through his damn face).

God. He had barely woken up and he was already so angry that even *staring* at shitty Deku's back made him want to punch him.

And shove him.

And just…

He sighed. Sitting up on the bed with a quick movement (which probably wasn't healthy for his spine) that made the mattress rattle, Katsuki grabbed his phone again and re-opened the text conversation with Deku's mom.

From: Katsuki Bakugou

I'll have to talk to Aizawa sensei to see if we can come over, but I'll let you know

He sighed, locked the phone and set it on his studying desk, staring – or rather glaring – at the floor. It was dusty. He probably needed to do a swiping soon. But he liked the way the dust sparkled and shone in the thin streaks of sunlight coming from the narrow gap between his curtains. It was distracting. And staring at it was better than staring at shitty Deku, or thinking about shitty Deku, or wondering what shitty Deku's freckles would look like beneath the sun, or trying to figure out why the fact that shitty Deku didn't want to talk to him and had that heartbreaking sadness etched all over his expressive eyes was fucking bothering him so much.

Fuck. What was Katsuki *doing*?

Being this evasive wasn't like him. Avoidance wasn't his damn type. If he had a problem, he faced it headfirst. If he needed to get something done, he did it with mastery. He wasn't a coward, and he wasn't the type to hide away from his problems and let them fucking consume him until they were too big to be dealt with. He always *acted* on stuff that bothered him.

Perhaps that was why he was so explosive. He didn't dwell on things, he didn't overthink. If something was bothering him, he confronted it impulsively. With his roaring shouts, with his

explosive fists, with whatever the hell he could get his hands on.

Or at least, that was what he used to be like… before he caused All Might's fall.

After all, *he* was the one who became the reason why the number one hero, the symbol of fucking *peace*, became nothing other than a tall, bony, lanky bastard who would probably break in half if anyone as much as poked him.

Katsuki hadn't confronted anyone about that, as he usually did. He couldn't have. Who could he confront? *Himself*?

(He should have).

He had let the hurt and the frustration and the anger grow inside himself and consume him until he needed to let it all out, until he needed to find a way to get rid of all that before he exploded. And the only way he found to do that was to fight Deku.

Because as close as he was to Kirishima, he couldn't just talk to him about *that*. Kirishima wouldn't understand. No one would. No one *could*. Not his few friends, not his teachers, certainly not his parents… he had been alone. He had been alone and addled with guilt and regret and resentment, and there was *nothing* he could have done but to keep all that inside himself, since his only alternative was letting it all out in the form of fire on his palms.

There was only one person who could understand.

Whether he would ever admit it to himself or not, he had a story with Deku. They had grown up together, for fuck's sake. They had known each other ever since they had learned how to walk. And, in the same way he knew Deku, despite of hating him (or having hated him, or whatever the fuck he felt about Deku now)… Deku knew him, too. Probably better than anyone.

No, that couldn't be true. They had grown up together, that was true, but as Katsuki had made very clear, they had never been friends. Deku might have thought they were friends at some point, but Katsuki never gave a damn about him. Deku didn't know him, and he couldn't read him better than Kirishima, who was his actual friend… Which was why Katsuki was so fucking *pissed*.

Despite everything, he knew the fucking hair-for-brains was right. He *was* bonding with Deku, whether he liked it or not. And what had once been hate… had been replaced with rivalry, and now with something else, something that Katsuki didn't fucking want to call *fondness*, but had no other word for. Because there was no way he would be thinking about Deku's stupid freckles and Deku's stupid hair unless there was some sort of… *fuck*. He didn't want to call it *fondness*. It wasn't fondness. It couldn't be.

Katsuki didn't feel… this f-word. For *anyone*. There were people who annoyed him more and people who annoyed him less. That was it. What he felt for his parents wasn't the f-word, either… He had never learned how to properly respect them, at least not in the same way other kids respected their parents, and they pissed him off more often than not. Surely,

Katsuki didn't dislike them… But he didn't think of them as perfect people enveloped by flowers, hearts, and chocolate, or whatever it was the f-word meant, either.

So yeah. He didn't feel the f-word for Deku. Whatever he was feeling… Whatever this tightness in his chest, these invasive thoughts, these weird, impulsive desires to reach out for Deku were… They were nothing but a side effect of the quirk who had separated Deku from his soul. Nothing less, nothing more. Maybe, if Katsuki was lucky, he would go right back to hating Deku as soon as the villain was found and this whole nightmare came to an end.

But who was he kidding? He had already stopped hating Deku before that quirk hit him. Before Deku… did what he did for him. But this feeling? This weird, creepy obsession thing his brain had going on, thinking about green hair and freckles and eyes and all that shit? That was not him. That had to be a result of the quirk, too. It *had* to.

Deku was the one who was obsessed with Katsuki, not the other way around. If there was one thing Deku was, was obsessed with him. He had *always* been. He had always followed Katsuki around, and tagged along even after Katsuki told him off, and kept praising him no matter how hard Katsuki bullied him. That had to be the result of some sort of obsession, right? And now that they were connected – now that their souls were literally *bound* to each other –, it only made sense that Deku's obsession seeped into Katsuki and made him obsessed with Deku as well. If they felt each other's feelings, then what Katsuki was feeling was probably just a mirror of Deku's own obsession, right? That was the only possible explanation. There was no way this could be something else.

Something *else*.

Katsuki didn't want to think about what it would mean if it *was* something else, so he decided to finally get off his ass and take a shower.

He really enjoyed taking showers – the longer, the better. His whole quirk relied on his sweating, so, in the shower, he never risked accidentally blowing up anything. He only ever took boiling-hot showers, and even if the heat made him sweat, the water washed it away before Katsuki could cause any damage, should he lose control.

It took him years to master the usage of his quirk. He knew he was a short-fuse, which always made it harder for him to keep a hold of his explosive power in the moments of most stress, and that was precisely why Katsuki had always trained so hard. He couldn't afford to lose it like an amateur in an actual fight against a villain. And after that sludge monster attacked him in the alley, a lifetime ago… He decided he would need a lot more training and a lot more hard working if he wanted to become the hero he aimed to become.

He used to be so arrogant back then. He was still arrogant, yes, but he had good reason, now. Before, he had been just a brat who thought too much of himself. A brat who had his head up his own ass and who couldn't see what was right in front of him. A brat who got way over his head and who… Who…

Who had to be saved by shitty Deku.

Katsuki leaned his head back as the fuming water fell on him, making the roar of the water running down his ears, jawline, and shoulder block away any other sound. He closed his eyes and took a deep breath. Focusing on the sound. Focusing on the heat.

He could still remember the way Deku had ran towards him. All bony and wimpy, all terrified. Shaking legs, trembling hands, eyes so wide they looked about to pop off their sockets. The way he threw his fucking backpack at an actual villain and tried to yank him off Katsuki using nothing but his scraping fingers. The way he had, once again, thought a pathetic loser like himself needed to save Katsuki.

(The way he was the only one who tried to save Katsuki.)

No matter how much he told Deku – or himself, for that matter – that he didn't need saving, Katsuki was well aware that he would have probably died if Deku hadn't stepped in on that day. For a long time, Katsuki had resented being saved by someone so inferior to him; he had resented Deku for looking down on him yet again. But after hearing All Might's tale about One For All and Deku's quirk… all Katsuki could feel was bittersweetness.

He constantly wondered if Deku would be there, at UA, with him and with a quirk, had Katsuki been stronger and freed himself from the sludge villain without aid.

He knew the answer.

All Might wouldn't have attested Deku's courage – not that Katsuki would ever call it *that* aloud – had Katsuki managed to fight back on his own. He would have probably gone on his way to find a new successor and Deku would have been left behind, still quirkless, still hopeless, still defenseless.

Katsuki didn't know how he felt about that. If anything, he was Deku's origin story, for better or for worse.

He didn't know how he felt about Deku at all.

But Katsuki knew that, if he had been stronger against the sludge villain, Deku's soul wouldn't be detached from his body right now. His body wouldn't be wasting away in a hospital bed, without visitors, without family, without friends.

He wouldn't be…

Katsuki didn't want to use that fucking word. Because Deku wasn't fucking… he wouldn't fucking d-word on his watch. Katsuki wouldn't allow it.

He decided thinking about Deku was just too complicated, and told himself that he had better things to spend his time on.

As he stepped out of the bathroom, a towel tied around his waist and his hair dripping wet, he was surprised to find Deku sitting up on the bed, clothes disheveled, hair as messy as ever, rubbing the sleep away from his eyes and looking like he had just woken up. Katsuki kept his eyes glued to the boy without realizing it as he made his way over to his wardrobe in order to

grab some fresh clothes, trying to figure out whether Deku would continue giving him the silent treatment or if they were already back at speaking terms.

Deku caught his eyes, assessed his half-naked form from head to toe, blushed slightly, and looked away in silence, seeming embarrassed. Katsuki could feel his own heart fluttering in a mimic of Deku's and rolled his eyes.

Really? Just the prospect of having to tell Katsuki *good morning* was making Deku this nervous? What a goddamn fucking wimp. Katsuki rolled his eyes and turned his back to Deku, searching for clothes to wear. He could feel the nerd's eyes glued to him, though, but when he turned to glare at him, Deku looked away again, redder than ever.

Coward. Couldn't even gather the balls to speak his mind. That was one of the things Katsuki hated the most about shitty Deku. He didn't know how to stand up for himself. He had always been a pathetic loser who relied on others to save him and protect him. Whenever he did try to protect himself, he failed. Katsuki had thought Deku had changed after he gained his quirk, but apparently, he was the same trembling coward he had always been.

Katsuki huffed out an annoyed breath as he made his way back to the bathroom to change his clothes, closing the door behind him. The steam from his hot shower still hovered thickly inside the bathroom, making the mirror blurry. After dressing up, Katsuki rubbed the mirror with his palm and stared at his reflection.

He had to admit he looked a bit tired. Probably because Deku's heavy-as-fuck sadness had weighted deep down on his chest and made him sleep for 6 more hours than he was used to. And he still felt *exhausted*, even after that.

Katsuki remembered with anger that Deku had told him something about needing to keep their feelings balanced in order not to tire each other out, and yes, Katsuki could admit (only to himself) that *maybe* he needed to control his anger a little better, but Deku, on the other hand, was doing an extremely shitty job at keeping his fucking overwhelming sadness at bay. How the fuck did he expect Katsuki to keep his damn cool if all he did all the time was mope and be sad about stuff without even trying to control it?

Katsuki reached the conclusion that what made him the maddest about all this whole thing wasn't Deku's sadness, but the fact that Deku never bothered to tell him what the fuck he was sad about. Yes, they had talked about it a couple times and, either times, Deku had made an association between his sadness, Katsuki, and the way he treated him, but what the *fuck* was he supposed to do? He knew he had been a total asshole to Deku – he still was, most of the time – , but he had also meant it when he said that what was in the past, was in the past.

Katsuki couldn't change what he had done. He couldn't take his words back. As terrible as they had been, Katsuki had meant them when he had said them. And some of what Deku had told him more recently about him thinking that quirks were everything… it urged some new considerations into Katsuki's mind; stuff he had never stopped to think about before. But it didn't change the fact that he had thought indeed, in the past, Deku was useless for being quirkless. And yes, now, as he grew older and spent more time with Deku, he could tell that he didn't begin seeing value in the nerd only because he had a quirk now.

But what could Katsuki possibly fucking do? He was trying to be less of an asshole to Deku. He couldn't help himself sometimes, and the only way he knew to interact with people was to call them names and mock them. That was part of his creation. His tone was always aggressive like that, it wasn't something Katsuki did on purpose and it was probably genetic. And, more importantly, the people who called themselves Katsuki's friends, out of their own free will and out of some deranged lack of common sense, didn't seem to *mind* these things about Katsuki's behavior. Surely, they often called his attention to it and criticized him for it whenever he went too far, but Katsuki could tell that, in the same way he meant no actual harm when he called Kirishima "Shitty Hair" or Mina "Raccoon Eyes", his friends didn't mean it when they called Katsuki grumpy and cranky. So why the fuck couldn't Deku just chill out a bit and be like them? They didn't get all hurt or touchy-feely when Katsuki yelled at them. That was something only Deku's oversensitive ass did.

Katsuki presumed Deku functioned in a different tone from the rest of his friends. He had always been a sensitive little asshole, always crying over anything, always whining and trembling and wobbling that lip of his. He used to cry so much as a kid that Katsuki teased him about that being his quirk, but that had made Deku cry even harder (to no one's surprise) and run home wailing. Katsuki couldn't imagine Kirishima or Kaminari having the same reaction to a comment of the same kind.

So yeah, maybe Deku was just a crybaby who couldn't get Katsuki's personality. Maybe they were out of tune with each other. And yeah, maybe Katsuki *was* an asshole who said unnecessary harsh truths to people sometimes. But his friends didn't care about him telling them harsh truths. Why did fucking Deku have to be such a crybaby about it? Things would be so much easier if Deku could just stop being upset over everything.

Either way, Katsuki could still feel Deku's sadness. He could feel it whenever he was a bit too rude, he could feel it whenever he said something a bit too harshly, and he could feel it right then, as he stared at his own tired reflection at the blurry mirror of his hot bathroom. He knew Deku was sad, he just didn't know why or how to fix it.

He also knew asking Deku about it would earn no results. The damn nerd was as stubborn as a mule when it came to admitting he was upset, and he only seemed to be able to tell Katsuki what the fuck was bothering him during heated discussions.

Now that Katsuki thought about it… Deku had only ever told him the reasons behind his sadness when he had been sharing Katsuki's anger. When he had absorbed Katsuki's anger into himself.

Huh.

Maybe Katsuki could simply make himself angry, get into a discussion with Deku and force him to tell him what was wrong and how to fix it, right?

But that would probably be exhausting as fuck. They always ended up tired and worn out after having a discussion, or after bearing each other's feelings. Katsuki, for example, had just slept for six extra hours and he was still feeling like he needed to lie down and take a power nap, just because he was feeling Deku's sadness. Purposefully triggering anger into Deku – or, better, purposefully making *himself* angry just so that *Deku* ended up being angry

and possibly spilled his feelings on him – didn't seem like a particularly good idea in that moment.

But feeling that sort of miserable sorrow was also *not* an option for him. Katsuki fucking hated moping, which was why the days he had spent blaming himself for All Might's end were the worse days of his life. He simply didn't have the emotional intelligence to deal with that sort of bullshit. For him, things were simpler – if something was upsetting him, he solved them. The All Might situation had taken him a little longer to solve – but, at the end of the day, he solved it, even if it had been by fighting Deku at the training grounds and getting himself house arrested.

So there was only thing Katsuki could do, really. He would have to solve this shit and put an end to Deku's sadness. He didn't know the cause for it, but he had a few ideas about how to make it go away, at least for a while.

Deku's mom's words echoed in his head as he made up his mind. *Don't think of his happiness as your happiness. Think of it as his own. For the time you are stuck together, and until the heroes find a solution… Please. Take care of him.*

As much as the idea annoyed the fuck out of him, Katsuki was a man of his damn word.

"Oh my god, I still can't believe we're going out with Kacchan!"

"I've already fucking told you not to call me that".

"Kaminari, don't spoil his mood or he'll never invite us out again!"

"Yeah, dude, she's right! Let's enjoy this rare moment of calmness and not piss *Kacchan* off!"

Kaminari and Sero started laughing very loudly, nudging each other in congratulation, while Mina rolled her eyes and Katsuki's scowl grew. Deku followed silently beside him, his face blank.

"I'm starting to fucking regret this", Katsuki growled angrily to no one in particular. He could tell Deku spared him a look at this, but didn't bother looking back at the boy.

"Are you telling that to me or to Midoriya?", Mina asked, taking Katsuki's other side while Kaminari and Sero trailed behind them in the mall, still laughing and making jokes.

“I’m telling that to myself”, Katsuki huffed out a breath of annoyance. “So that next time I come up with this sort of shit, I can talk myself out of it using my previous *shitty* experience”.

“Aah, don’t be so grumpy!”, Mina exclaimed, throwing an arm around Katsuki’s shoulders and pulling him closer to her. Katsuki allowed the girl to hold him for a couple of seconds before shrugging away from the touch with even more annoyance on his face. “We’re going to have fun, you’ll see! They just like being assholes because you get all cute when you’re pissed off, Kacchan!”

“The *fuck* did you say?!”, Katsuki turned at her abruptly with a furious snarl on his face, holding a popping palm at his side with rage.

Mina looked terrified but giggled nervously all the same, staying behind a little so that she could catch up with Kaminari and Sero (and at a safe distance from the fuming Katsuki). Katsuki huffed out another breath of annoyance and hunched over even more, shoving his smoking hands into his pockets and scowling.

“Fucking pink raccoon with her fucking shitty jokes. I don’t even know why I fucking bothered”, he muttered to himself.

“What are we even doing here, Kacchan?”, Deku asked him with a tired sigh, addressing him for the first time on that day. He sounded as if the banter between Katsuki and his friends was more than he was willing to put up with but he had no choice other than endure it, which, quite honestly, wasn’t the result Katsuki had been expecting to earn with all this.

Deku had been silent as he woke up, as Katsuki changed into fresh clothes, as Katsuki told him they were going out. He had been so fucking silent that it was driving Katsuki insane. And this – this fucking moment – was the first time he chose to speak up. Using *that* displeased tone of voice. For some reason, it made Katsuki’s blood boil.

“What the *fuck* do you think we’re in a shopping mall for exactly?”, he asked aggressively, and that was all it took to send Deku into a silent spiral again. Taking a glimpse at the quiet boy, Katsuki sighed, tightening his hands into fists.

Fine. If they didn’t want to be tired, they had to find balance, right? Katsuki would find his fucking balance. He would be so fucking balanced that there would be no way that shitty Deku would manage to shove the blame on him for them feeling so tired all the time, and maybe then he would finally put some effort into fixing his own sadness instead of leaving all the hard work to Katsuki. So, meaning to act like a more reasonable person and be civil – or as civil as possible – to Deku, Katsuki added, after a few moments:

“Kirishima’s birthday is coming up, so I’m gonna buy the motherfucker a gift or some shit like that”.

The effect his words had on Deku was the opposite Katsuki had expected. If anything, the boy simply shrunk further into himself and avoided his eyes even more. Katsuki huffed out a frustrated breath, suppressing the anger threatening to overtake him. *You don’t want to sleep*

the day away. You don't want to feel so fucking tired, right? So take a deep breath and calm the fuck down.

"We're going over to your mom's after we're done here", Katsuki added after a few more moments without any previous warning when Deku didn't offer him any sort of response or acknowledgement. His tone was flat and bored, as if that information wasn't a big deal for Deku.

Deku did look at him this time, his eyes painted with something that resembled hesitant expectation, as if he didn't want to put his hopes up. The thought that Deku could be thinking Katsuki would say something like that as a joke, as a mean to trick him, made his hands tighten even more. *Deep breaths. Deep* fucking *breaths*.

"Why the fuck are you giving me that look?", Katsuki scoffed, struggling to hold his words back. "I'm not kidding or whatever the crap it is you're thinking. We're going to see your damn mom", he growled, before turning his head away from Deku and angrily continuing to stomp his way across the mall.

The place was crowded, which probably meant the UA escort Aizawa sensei had sent with them would easily lose sight of them, which in its turn meant they needed to get their business over with at once and just get the hell out of there soon. Deku, who was invisible to everyone at the mall except for Katsuki, kept phasing himself through hurrying passerby, since he had no way to prevent it.

"Kacchan", Izuku called after a while, reaching out for Katsuki and grabbing his wrist. Katsuki couldn't stop, otherwise several people would bump into him and he would end up exploding their faces because he *hated* being bumped, so he kept on walking with Deku attached to his arm like a lost toddler. "T-Thank you", he added when it became clear that Katsuki wasn't stopping.

Katsuki did turn to look at him at this, a confused scowl on his face.

"The fuck for?", Katsuki asked, noticing that a few people surrounding him on the mall sent him confused looks upon his words. He opted to ignore them. Izuku, on the other hand, looked almost embarrassed and ashamed, even though Katsuki had no idea what he could be ashamed of.

Izuku lowered his head, looked aside, bit his lower lip and sighed as Katsuki continued walking. Several moments passed without him saying anything.

Deep. Fucking. Breaths.

"How long are you gonna keep giving me this silent treatment for, huh?", Katsuki asked, calling Izuku's (as well as many other passerby's) attention. He didn't wait for a response before continuing: "Because I know I told you I'm not begging for you to talk to me, *hell* no, but I don't even know what the fuck I did this time to get you all like this", he admitted. There was no denying the curiosity about Deku's sudden gloominess was driving him fucking nuts.

Izuku seemed pensive for a moment, before bowing his head in embarrassment.

What could he say? Kacchan was right. He had no reason – or right, on that matter – to be mad at Kacchan for being friends – or whatever he was – with Kirishima. Sure, Izuku couldn't help feeling hurt, but giving Kacchan the silent treatment was not only unnecessary but suspicious. Izuku could feel how hard Kacchan was trying to keep his own anger at bay, trying to prevent it from overwhelming him… Why couldn't he do the same with his hurt and his sadness? Why couldn't Izuku at least try to find a balance in the same way Kacchan was (surprisingly) doing?

Izuku realized with (unintentional) sadness that he wasn't really good at telling when his miserable feelings were overwhelming him, unless Kacchan brought his attention to it. He supposed he did grow up a lonely, sad kid – not having a quirk or friends who cared about him contributed to that a lot. He probably got so used to the sadness that he couldn't feel when it was overwhelming him anymore… Which was most likely the reason why they were feeling so constantly tired. Because Izuku was constantly sad, without even being aware of it.

Izuku decided he couldn't keep that up anymore. He needed to rest. His body could obviously use it. And Kacchan – as much as he tried to hide it and pretend everything was fine, Izuku could tell he was exhausted too – probably more so after Izuku's miserable night.

So it didn't matter if Kacchan's close friendship with Kirishima made Izuku sad or jealous or resentful or whatever it was he was feeling. He couldn't change that, and, in fact, he didn't want to change that. Deep down, he was glad that Kacchan had managed to find himself some real friends, and not those bad-company bullies that hung with him at school. Kirishima, along with the rest of Kacchan's friends, was obviously a good influence on the boy, and he was undeniably an amazing person. Kacchan seemed more mature after he befriended Kirishima, and he was constantly improving himself, now. Izuku wished he could be Kacchan's friend, too – actually, he wished he could be as close to Kacchan as Kirishima was –, but he was also happy for Kacchan.

It was ugly of Izuku to feel mad because of Kirishima and he knew it. Kirishima had always been nice to him; in fact, he had never been anything *but* nice to him. He was a good, supportive, cheerful friend, and he and Kacchan got along so well. Izuku had never seen Kacchan get along with someone so well, so he should be happy, right, there was no reason for him not to be happy, why wasn't he happy, he needed to be happy, if he wasn't happy then neither of them would be able to rest and if they didn't rest his body would get worse and Kacchan would get angrier and Izuku just couldn't find the words to explain the reason behind his sadness because looking Kacchan in the eyes and saying "I'm miserable because I want to be close friends with you but you don't want anything to do with me and you already have cool friends and I already have cool friends so we clearly don't need each other anymore, not that you ever needed me in the first place, but it makes me sad to think what we could have had if you hadn't been such an ass to me when we were growing up and what we could have had if I had been born with a quirk or what he could still have if you just stopped being so stubborn and gave me a chance of showing you that we fit so well together".

"Ok, that's enough", Katsuki broke him away from his rushed train of thought, suddenly shoving the door to the mall's bathroom open and dragging Izuku inside with him. Izuku

hadn't even realized they had been headed to the bathroom, so lost in thought as he had been.

There weren't many people inside, only two men, so Katsuki marched his way to the last bathroom stall and slammed the door closed with more force than necessary after the two of them were inside. They stood there, in the confined space, a toilet seat standing behind them as Katsuki crossed his arms above his chest and glared at Deku with pure annoyance.

"You were the piece of shit who mumbled something at me about 'keeping our feelings balanced' or whatever the hell it is you meant", he growled. "But there's something clearly upsetting you since yesterday night, and I'm done playing guessing games with you. I'm fucking *exhausted*, I tried to get you out to see if you could cheer your miserable ass up a bit, and then I told you I was taking you to see your mom after I was fucking done here, and that *still* wasn't enough to make our stupid fucking chest stop feeling so tight. So will you just tell me what the fuck is going on? Or do you want me to find a way to shove happiness down your throat with my bare hands and be done with this shit?"

Izuku stared up at Katsuki, opening and closing his mouth in hesitation and loss for words. What could he say? How could he explain? How could he put it into words? He hadn't expected Kacchan to confront him like this –

"*Just fucking spit it, damn Deku*!", Katsuki yelled at his lack of response, slamming one of his hands on the bathroom stall wall beside him with anger. The shouting and the slamming probably scared away the men who had been inside the bathroom, and quite possibly any other possible man who attempted to use the bathroom after they entered. Izuku flinched at the loud sound, but didn't take his eyes off Katsuki, an almost-defiance etched in them.

"I –", he started, swallowing dry and hesitating. Katsuki continued to glare at him, but didn't look like he was about to make any interruptions. "I – It's because I don't – I don't really know how to, uh. How to force myself. To be happy".

Katsuki stared at him.

"What?"

"I mean, I am happy", he continued, nervous. "I am a happy person. Especially at this point in my life, and after everything I've conquered. But… Sometimes, I get – I get sad. And it's normal".

"It isn't fucking normal to feel so fucking sad all the time".

"Well, I don't have many reasons *not* to be sad being in the situation I'm in, Kacchan", Izuku pointed out. "B-But what I mean is… It happens, sometimes. And – And I'm s-sorry", he added sincerely, because he felt as if those words needed to be said. "That you end up miserable too, because of me. But I just – I can't *force* myself to be happy all the time. Sometimes, all I can do is – w-wait for it to pass".

Katsuki continued to stare at him for a few moments before sighing and rolling his eyes.

“Fine, but that isn’t my fucking question”, he shook his head in annoyance. “My question is – what the fuck is upsetting you right now, and how can we fix it so you stop being so fucking sappy”.

“That’s my *point*, Kacchan”, it was Izuku’s turn to sigh. “It’s not something that can be fixed. Just leave it, and I’ll be fine in no time, ok?”

“*Hell* fucking *no*”, Katsuki scoffed at him as if the suggestion was ridiculous. “You tell me what it is, then I’ll decide if it can or can’t be fixed”.

For some reason, the statement overwhelmed Izuku with annoyance, and he found himself glaring at Katsuki.

“I think I know my feelings well enough to tell if they can be fixed”, he pointed out, ending up sounding a bit too defensive. Katsuki scoffed at him again with a scornful look on his face.

“I think you fucking don’t”, he said simply, shrugging.

“What?”

“Deku, I can feel what you fucking feel. This works both ways, remember?”, he gestured at the empty space between them. “And you feel way too many fucking emotions at the same time to be able to tell them from each other. But it’s fucking clear that something triggered this shitshow, and I want to know what the fuck it was because I honestly have no idea. And if I have no idea, I can’t know if there’s a way to fix it. So you’d better spill your damn beans to me right now if you don’t want your shitty soul to get an asskicking”.

Izuku continued to glare at Katsuki, some of the boy’s anger slipping into him.

“What if I don’t want to tell you?”

“Ah, there you *fucking go* again. *Seriously*, Deku?”

“I mean it. I don’t have any obligation to tell you. You never tell me why you’re angry; why should I tell you why I’m sad?”

Katsuki stared at him for an eternity.

“What the fuck do you mean?”

“It’s true! Why don’t you tell me why you’re so angry, huh?”

“I’m angry ‘cause you’re being a piece of fucking shit who’s making me exhausted with all your feelings and you refuse to tell me why!”

“Fine! Then why were you angry yesterday? And the day before that? And every single day before that? Why are you always so angry, Kacchan?”

“I don’t know! I don’t fucking know! What does this have to do with any fucking thing?!”

“It has to do with the fact that you make me tired, too! Right now I’m taking half of your anger and it’s already enough to make me want to punch some sense into you!”

“*Try it*, you damn fucking nerd”.

“And whenever I end up with all of it, it makes me feel like I’m about to burst from the inside out! I have no idea how you keep all this inside of yourself, but I don’t pressure you into talking about it!”

“Then what are you doing right now, huh?”

“I’m trying to make you see, for once! Because you never do! You never see what’s right in front of you when it’s really important!”

“What the fuck does that mean?”

“It means you’re amazing, Kacchan!”

“What the *fuck*?!”

“It means you’re really amazing, because you’re terrific at looking past your anger when you’re in battle, and when you’re thinking strategically, and when you’re acting as a hero. But the moment it is important – the *moment* you need to set your anger aside and just open your eyes, you don’t do it! No matter how close the truth is to your face!”

“I have no fucking idea what you’re talking about”, Katsuki shook his head.

“I’m talking about *me*!”, Izuku cried. “I’m talking about all those times I trailed after you, and praised you, and admired you, and you spent all these years, you spent *all these years* thinking I was looking down on you! Because of your stupid, blinding anger!”, his voice came out wobbly and shaky.

Katsuki scoffed, shaking his head in silence.

“So this shit is still about *that*? About the way I treated you as a kid?”

Izuku shook his head too.

“This *shit* is about *you*, Kacchan. Why can’t you just see?”

“See *what*?”

Izuku sniffed and ran the back of his hand beneath his nose, looking hurt and angry.

“What, Deku? What the fuck is it that you see and I don’t? Why the fuck do you get so upset every other day about the same damn reason?”, he scoffed. “You want to talk about it? *Again*? Is that all you ever want to fucking talk about?”

Izuku was silent.

“Fine. I was an asshole. I fucking know that, *you* fucking know that. The whole damn world fucking knows that. What else do you want me to tell you?”

Silence.

“Nothing I say can take back what I did. Nothing I do can erase what I’ve done. I’m trying to be fucking better, because that’s the only thing I can do, but you’re not making it fucking easy on me because whenever the fuck I try to be more reasonable and talk to you like you so wanted me to, you give me the cold shoulder and the silent treatment as if I fucking owe you something. And I *don’t*”.

Silence.

“Just because I was an asshole, doesn’t mean I’m indebted for life with you. I’m fucking trying, ok? I’m trying, and you’re not helping, and it’s pissing the fuck out of me, so just get your shit together and figure out what the fuck it is you want me to do, because honestly, I’m getting fed up with this”.

Izuku lowered his head, Katsuki’s anger leaving him entirely and being replaced by his own sadness again. He didn’t look at the boy in front of him.

“I told you to tell me when I was being an asshole to you. So if whatever got you so sad has to do with me, just *tell* me”.

Silence.

“I’m not fucking good at this, Deku. I’m good at everything else, but not at this feelings shit. So just tell me what the fuck is going on, because I’m tired, and I need a nap, and I’m so *done* with this empathic link bullshit”.

A long time passed before Izuku responded, sounding ashamed.

“Y-You’re – You’re right, Kacchan. I shouldn’t have given you the silent treatment. And – I shouldn’t have yelled. I’m sorry”.

“Never mind the fucking yelling, just tell me how to make you happy”.

Izuku finally lifted his head to look at Katsuki, a mixture of longing, misery, hope, and pain etched all over his features. Katsuki scowled, realizing how his words must have sounded.

“That came out wrong”.

“It’s ok”.

“*Whatever*, shitty Deku. Just fucking – *tell* me”.

Izuku sighed.

“I don’t think I’m ready to talk about it. But – don’t worry”, he added before Katsuki could protest. “I know you’ve been trying to control your anger, even if it hasn’t been working –“

“*Eh?!*”

“ – so I’ll work harder on controlling my sadness, too. You won’t have to worry about it anymore, ok?”

“Don’t pull this self-sacrificing bullshit on me again”, Katsuki grabbed Izuku’s forearm and pulled him closer in the confined space of the bathroom stall. “I don’t give a shit if you’re messed up in the head and like to suffer. I’m not asking why you’re sad and trying to fix this shit just because I’m fucking tired”.

“Then why?”, Izuku asked, eyes almost innocent.

Katsuki let go of him abruptly, looking annoyed.

“You know why”.

A scoff.

“Because you made a promise to my mom”.

Katsuki was silent.

“Seriously, Kacchan?”

“I’m a man of my fucking word”.

A twinge of pain. Izuku sighed, knowing they both had felt it.

“I wish you actually cared, you know”.

Katsuki studied for a long moment.

“Is this what this is about?”

“No. Yes. I don’t – I don’t know”.

“You’re sad because you wish I cared about you?”

“I think it’s because I wish we were actual friends”.

“And why the fuck is that?”

“Huh?”

“Why the fuck do you want to be my friend so badly?”

“B-Because – Because I – I –“

“Quit the fucking stuttering, you know I hate this crap”.

Izuku took a deep breath.

“Because, despite everything, I still think you’re amazing. I always have”.

Katsuki stared.

“And I care about you. Is it too much to wish you would care about me back?”

The silence that followed was so overwhelming that it was almost deafening. The whole world was reduced to that one bathroom stall, in that one shopping mall, in that single point in space-time.

“You… can’t force yourself to be happy”, Katsuki said, long after Deku’s question had stopped echoing in his ears.

“Yeah”, Izuku responded, feeling his heart sink.

I can’t force myself to care about you, either.

The words were left unsaid. Katsuki didn’t have to say them. Izuku was smart enough to understand that the silence that lingered in the air were enough of an answer.

What Izuku didn’t know was that this was a lie.

Katsuki didn’t want him to know this was a lie. He didn’t even know *why* this was a lie in the first place. No matter how much he tried, he couldn’t pinpoint the exact moment when he stopped hating Deku; the exact moment he started caring about him. Surely, he had managed to convince himself that his promise to Inko was the sole reason why he decided to be gentler with Deku and focus more on his well-being with no second intentions, but still… He couldn’t deny that he cared for Deku on his own, with no promises, even if only an itsy, tiny bit.

But he didn’t want Deku to know that.

Maybe it was for fear of appearing weak, even if Katsuki didn’t care about anyone else’s opinions. Maybe it was for another secret reason that he didn’t really understand.

Either way, Deku couldn’t know. So he said nothing. He didn’t reply to Deku’s question, and instead flushed the toilet between them, only not to raise suspicion from possible outside listeners. He unceremoniously opened the stall door and walked out, trusting that Deku would follow.

Deku was still sad.

Katsuki made his way to the sink. There was a man there. The man who was escorting them, from UA.

“That was one hell of a phone call you made there”, the man told him, probably trying to keep discretion in front of the other person that was with them inside the bathroom.

“None of your business”, Katsuki said simply, pretending to wash his hands.

“You should probably get going. There’s only so much a person can do in a day, right?”

“We just got here”.

“Your friends are waiting for you in the second floor. You should meet them”.

“What are you now, my dad?”

The escort stared at him with a serious look in his eyes.

“I’ll wait for you outside”.

“Just listen to him”, Deku said tiredly beside him, sounding resentful. “He wouldn’t be saying this unless it was to protect us”.

Katsuki decided not to respond, and walked out of the bathroom.

Instead of heading to the pointed location, Katsuki made his way to a Crimson Riot store at the fourth floor, bought Kirishima a nice plush of the boy’s favorite hero, and took Deku’s distraction with the amount of merchandise to buy two All Might limited edition keychains.

Deku wasn’t exactly tangible at the moment and they were in the middle of a crowded store, so Katsuki shoved one of the keychains he had just bought in his pocket and walked out of the store, holding the bag with the Crimson Riot plush with one hand and fiddling with the keychain he had bought himself with the other. The keychain he would give Deku sat heavily in his pocket, rattling with each step he took as if a constant reminder. *I’m here. You can’t ignore me. You can’t pretend I’m not right here. And you do care about me*.

Unfortunately, Katsuki only knew a few ways to show he cared for someone.

“This is fucking ridiculous”.

“Get in the car”.

“Why?”

“Because if you don’t, UA won’t allow you to take these out-of-grounds strolls anymore”.

“And then what will you do? Put me in house arrest or some shit?”

“Just get in the car, Kacchan”.

“If that’s what it takes to guarantee your safety, yes”.

“That’s fucking *illegal*”.

“It isn’t, actually”.

“You’ll find that it’s not. You’re an underage student who recently survived an attack from a villain who is still on the loose, and who could be seeking revenge against you or Midoriya-kun. We have a legal responsibility to protect you, which is why you should get in the car”.

“I can take the fucking train. I did it last time”.

“Last time you didn’t disappear from your supervisor’s eye range for over ten minutes inside a potentially dangerous environment”.

“So you’re punishing me for taking a long shit?”

“Giving you a ride is not punishment. And we both know what you were doing in the bathroom”.

“Oh, yeah? What do you think *you* know?”

“*Kacchan*”.

“Do you really want to talk about the argument I heard you have with Midoriya-kun?”

Silence.

“Get in the car”.

“I’ll take the fucking train”.

“Don’t make me call Eraser Head”.

“You know what, I don’t appreciate your fucking tone”.

“Just get in the car, Kacchan”.

“And I don’t appreciate your behavior from today. My job is to make sure you’re safe, and, more importantly, that you don’t get captured, injured, or killed. If you don’t want to be treated like a child, don’t act like one”.

“The *fuck* did you just say to me?”

Izuku grabbed one of Katsuki’s arms, holding him back.

“You could have notified me you would be gone for so long. We thought someone could have kidnapped you”.

Again, was the word that lingered unsaid in the air.

“Why the fuck would I do that? I don’t have to tell you every time I go to the bathroom –“

“You do, if you plan on taking more than ten minutes to come out. There wasn’t a line”.

“There’s never a line”.

“Precisely. Look”, he sighed tiredly, “Eraser entrusted me to keep a close eye on you and prevent anything bad from happening. It’s not just your life that’s on the line if you get injured or killed. We don’t know what would happen to Midoriya-kun if that happened”.

A pause, and an angry sigh. Katsuki glared at the man, taking his words into consideration.

Shit. He hadn’t thought about that.

“Fine. I’ll get in your fucking car”.

“Good. And next time, don’t disappear like that. There are rules you have to obey to ensure your safety”.

“If you keep talking to me, I’ll throw myself out the window and blow your damn car up”.

Izuku did try to hide the tiny smile that blossomed in his lips at this as he sat beside Kacchan. Before the car started, Katsuki enveloped Izuku’s shoulders with one of his arms, not looking at him, as if this was no big deal.

“Don’t want the train shit to happen again”, he justified in a deadpan, even though he didn’t really have to, staring out the window and pretending the close contact with Deku wasn’t giving him all sorts of mixed feelings.

Izuku decided not to answer, lest Katsuki notice the forming blush on his cheeks.

“Katsuki-kun! I’m really glad you could make it!”, Inko greeted as she opened the door, stepping aside so that the boy could walk into the apartment and bearing a shy smile. Katsuki stepped in with his usual grumpy expression, Deku trailing close behind him, but he nodded at Inko once she closed the door and turned to him. “Did you have lunch yet?”, she asked, approaching him.

“No”, Katsuki answered, hands shoved deep in his pockets and face tilted slightly away from Inko so that he wouldn’t have to meet her eyes.

“Good. We can eat together, then”, Inko’s smile widened a little, but the look didn’t match the tiredness of her face. Her hair, which was part-tied into a bun as usual, looked dry and unkempt, several strands falling off the top of her bun ungracefully. She looked worse than she had when Katsuki last visited, and as she walked towards the open kitchen of her apartment, Katsuki noticed how… thinner she looked. Less chubby.

He remembered Inko as a taller, thinner, prettier woman during their childhood than she was now. It was true that he had spent years without seeing her, but this… Katsuki could tell she wasn’t doing fine. She was probably missing sleep and meals, if her state was anything to go by.

He turned his head to stare at Deku, who was looking at his mom with an extremely worried expression on his face. Well, at least some of the sadness had gone away, but it hadn’t been replaced by happiness, as Katsuki had been aiming to. If anything, Deku was more worried and nervous in that moment.

Katsuki sighed, rolling his eyes. Deku turned to look at him with a worried frown, the expressive damn fucking eyes Katsuki hated so much telling him everything he needed to know.

Katsuki was feeling tired as fuck after the shitshow of confusing emotions he was sharing with Deku ever since the previous night. But he obviously wasn’t *as* tired as Inko Midoriya, who was struggling to remove a tray from inside the oven.

“Let me”, he stepped in, gently nudging her aside with one hand and taking her place in removing the tray from the oven with his bare hands.

“No, wait, your hands –!”, Inko tried to stop him, but Katsuki grabbed the tray and placed it on the counter with no effort or pain. Inko stared at him with wide eyes that mimicked the way Deku was also looking at him, as if neither of them had ever seen them before. Katsuki stared back at them with a blank, bored expression.

“Do you want me to put this on the table?”, he asked in a deadpan. Inko blinked at him several times.

“Didn’t – didn’t you – y-your – your hands…”, she stuttered, very much like Deku usually did. It annoyed Katsuki, but not as much as he would have expected.

“They’re ok”, Katsuki explained as if that was obvious. “If my hands were sensitive to heat, my quirk would have fucked me up a long time ago”.

Inko frowned. Katsuki was pretty sure it had nothing to do with his use of profanity.

“B-But Katsuki-kun…”, Inko said, stepping closer to him and gently taking hold of one of his hands. “They’re red. What – What if they blister…?”

“They won’t”, Katsuki interrupted. He didn’t remove his hand from Inko’s touch.

“A-Are you sure…?”, she asked, frowning and looking deeply concerned.

“Yeah. Done it a thousand times”, he added in a deadpan. Inko pursed her lips into a thin line and her frown deepened, but eventually she nodded, staring up at him with a serious frown.

“Alright. You go sit by the table; I can bring everything else on my own”, she told him, trying to put on a tiny reassuring smile and failing. The bags under her eyes were dark.

“I can help you”, Katsuki said, finally freeing his hand from her touch and closing the oven door.

“Oh, please, Katsuki-kun, you’re my guest…”, Inko waved a hand at him with a discrediting chuckle, but Katsuki could tell that, even though she meant her words, she was too tired to properly protest. Ignoring her, he grabbed the hot tray and took it to the dining table without a word.

To his surprise, Deku followed him instead of lingering close to his mom, who stayed at the kitchen. Katsuki sent him a curious – albeit bored – look as he placed the tray on the table.

“You lied to her”, Izuku accused him, though his voice didn’t sound angry or hurt. Just… observant.

“Did I?”, he raised an inquiring eyebrow at the boy.

“About your hands”, Izuku explained, sounding purposefully vague as if he wanted Katsuki to give him an explanation without having to ask him for one.

“Don’t assume you know anything about that”, he warned with a half-hearted glare.

“They did hurt”, Izuku pointed out, sounding concerned. “I could feel it”.

“Must have been psychosomatic”.

“No, it wasn’t”, he grabbed hold of one of Katsuki’s hand, turning it so that his red, raw palm would be facing up. “You hurt yourself”.

“I didn’t feel anything”, Katsuki removed his hand from Izuku’s hold, heading back to the kitchen.

“Are you serious?”, Izuku frowned, following him.

“Yeah. They’ve calloused over the years; I don’t feel any pain in them anymore. You probably only did because you have soft baby hands”.

“I don’t!”, Izuku protested.

“Yeah, you do”.

“Kacchan –“

“Stop talking about it”.

“Promise me you’re saying the truth”.

“I don’t owe you any fucking thing”.

“I’m serious, Katsuki-kun. I can handle it –“, Inko tried to protest as Katsuki removed the pots and cups she was (struggling to carry) in her arms, interrupting whatever it was her son was about to say. She looked embarrassed by this. Instead of responding, Katsuki turned around and headed back to the dining table, setting everything in place. He could feel Deku’s eyes glued on him but ignored him.

As he turned around to head back to the kitchen, Inko was already there, holding another tray with mittens to protect her hands. She placed the tray on the table silently and removed her mittens, as well as her apron. He grabbed the tray with his bare hands and, realizing that there was nothing else to bring from the kitchen, Katsuki walked back to the dining room and took a seat, pulling the chair beside Inko for Deku to seat (since the boy couldn’t pull it on his own).

After placing the mittens and the apron back in the kitchen, Inko returned and began to serve their food. Katsuki let her do that on her own, since the woman looked like she would burst into tears if Katsuki tried to do anything else for her again.

“How is my Izuku doing?”, she asked without looking at him as she handed him his pot of – surprise, surprise – katsudon. Katsuki vaguely wondered if he would be forced to eat katsudon all the time while Deku was glued to him, but shit, if it made the nerd slightly happier, even if just for a while, he would eat that shit as if there was no tomorrow. It wasn’t Katsuki’s favorite dish, but he had nothing against it, either, and it always seemed like the right answer to make the little shit happy. He took the tray from Inko and gave Izuku a questioning glimpse.

“Don’t tell her about my body”, Izuku said quietly, even though his mom wouldn’t be able to hear him anyway. “She’s already worried enough”.

There were several things Katsuki wanted to say. *What am I supposed to tell her then, asshat? That you’re fine and happy and everything in your soul-life is sunshine and flowers? Because that’s bullshit and we both know it*.

“He’s been coping”, Katsuki shrugged without looking at Inko, taking a mouthful of the food and chewing.

“C-Coping…?”, Inko asked, looking extremely concerned, as if that wasn’t the answer she had been expecting.

“Yeah. He can only feel so well while he’s a ghost”, Katsuki shrugged again, continuing to eat. Upon Inko’s grim silence, Katsuki looked at her, only to find a miserable look on her face. Glancing at Deku, he found an identical look on his face, only it had something else… Something that almost resembled anger. Perhaps Katsuki’s answer had been too honest for Deku’s liking. “He’s fine. It’s just tiring, for both of us”, he added in the hopes to reassure the worried mother.

Inko looked up at him, her food untouched on the pot in front of her. She didn't look like she was about to eat, either.

"What do you mean?", she asked, sounding hesitant.

"The sharing feelings shit", Katsuki said, taking another mouthful. "It tires us out. When I feel his feelings, and when he feels my feelings… it always leaves us exhausted. We're trying to figure it out", he pointed Deku with a knowing glance.

"And w-what…", Inko lowered her head, looking determined and hesitant. "What is he feeling? Now?", she frowned at Katsuki, almost as if she feared to be invading her son's privacy but needed to know anyway.

Katsuki fixed his eyes on Izuku, who stared back at him with an unfaltering gaze. He tried to separate his emotions from Deku's, because he knew that asking the nerd about it would earn no results. Even if figuring out what the fuck Deku was feeling would probably be hard, it would also probably be easier than trying to urge a sincere response from the little shit.

All right. So, there was sadness, even though it was weaker than before. Katsuki didn't know if that was thanks to the katsudon, or to his mom, or both. There was concern, obviously, since Deku's mom looked like shit, and also love (also for his mom, obviously; who else would it be for?). In a rare stance, Deku's feelings weren't too many or too confusing to read this time. He raised an eyebrow at Deku, as if asking whether or not he could share his feelings with his mom, and Deku simply nodded back at him, not saying anything. He was quieter than usual.

"He's happy to be here", Katsuki turned to look at Inko, who was staring at him with expectation. "But he's also worried about you".

He decided to leave the sadness part out. Inko didn't need to have that on her plate.

"W-Worried?", she frowned, a confused, fond smile appearing on her lips. "H-He has no reason to be worried –", she started, but Katsuki sighed.

"Look, he's sitting right beside you. You don't have to talk as if he isn't right there; it makes him all miserable and shit", he said, a bit more harshly than he had intended. Inko's eyes widened and she blinked in surprise, hesitantly looking at her side, where her son was sitting invisible. She lowered her gaze and her shoulders slumped, making her look even more tired, as well as guilty. Izuku, on the other hand, stared at Katsuki as if he had just revealed one of Izuku's deepest secret to his mother.

Katsuki took another mouthful of his food with indifference and continued to eat as Inko shifted on her seat, as if to face Izuku. She clearly couldn't see him, as her eyes searched vacantly through the nothingness in front of her, but she still turned on her seat towards her ghost son. Izuku's attention shifted towards his mother, even though he still looked a little betrayed by Katsuki's reveal.

"I'm sorry, Izuku", she started sincerely, her voice thick with guilt, worry, and sorrow. She was no longer trying to look at him, since she couldn't see him, but at least she was turned

towards anyway.

“Mom”, Izuku said softly, lifting a hand to touch his mother’s face lovingly, even though she couldn’t feel him and he couldn’t feel her.

“It’s just… It’s hard for me to remember that you’re still here when I can’t see you, you know?”, she added, sounding like she was on the verge of tears.

As Katsuki spared Deku a glimpse, he saw the boy was on the verge of tears as well, and rolled his eyes, continuing to eat. He felt like he was intruding on a personal moment and wanted desperately to leave, but he also knew he couldn’t. He was literally their only means of communication, and he *hated* it. He hated this sentimental bullshit, this lack of objectiveness. It made him a bit sick.

“But mom will try to be better, ok?”, she continued, sniffing and completely unaware of the grumpy look on Katsuki’s face. “Mom is here for you… Even if she can’t see you. I’m here for you, Izuku”.

Deku started to cry at this, sniffing, gasping, and choking on his breath. *At least he isn’t sobbing*, Katsuki thought to himself as he continued to eat his katsudon. *I can’t stand it when he sobs*.

Izuku immediately started sobbing, his face scrunching up in an ugly grimace as he desperately tried to hug his mom and failed.

Ah, fucking great.

“I’m sorry, mom”, Izuku was saying in between sobs, his intangible fingers trying to clutch at her clothes. “I’m sorry. I know I promised I would stop worrying you. I’m sorry, I’m so sorry. I didn’t mean to do this to you”.

“He’s trying to hug you and crying about not meaning to make you worried”, Katsuki relayed the message in a deadpan, not looking at Inko as he chewed down his food.

Fuck, he hadn’t even realized how hungry he had been until he started eating. Maybe exhaustion wasn’t the only toll Deku’s soul took on him.

Inko stared at Katsuki for a few seconds of surprised silence before turning back towards where she assumed Izuku was sitting, a sad smile on her wobbly lips.

“You don’t need to apologize, baby”, she sniffed, looking like she was trying her best to put up a strong, reassuring façade for her son. “You know how mom is. She worries a lot, because… Because you’re everything, Izuku. Oh, baby, you’re everything to me”, she broke down, covering her face with both hands in a meek attempt to hide her tears. Her shoulders rattled with her muffled sobs, and Katsuki closed his eyes so that no one could see him rolling them. “I’m sorry I can’t touch you, Izuku”, she gasped, not looking at him, her weeping eyes covered away from view. Katsuki realized it was easier for her to talk like that, rather than try, fruitlessly, to see a son that was invisible to her. “I wish I could hug you right now”, she added with a tiny sob that Izuku immediately mimicked.

“I wish I could hug you, too”, he cried, his hands still trying to caress his mother’s arm and touch her hair. Katsuki only half-watched through his peripheral vision as he continued to eat his food, pretending not to pay attention with a meticulously calculated indifference painting his face.

“He wishes he could hug you, too”, Katsuki said in another deadpan after a small delay where he was unsure whether he should relay the message or not, not looking at either of them. Shit, the things he had to do to make the little shitty nerd happy. Katsuki hoped that acting as a delivery boy without shitty Deku having to beg him for it would at least improve the nerd’s mood somehow.

“You can count on me for anything”, Inko continued, finally removing her hands from her face and trying to look at Izuku again, even though she couldn’t find him. Looking at her wrecked face, Katsuki didn’t know whether he should say or do something a bit more sensitive or not, especially since Inko looked like she was about to break down any second now. “Mom has trouble remembering you’re still around, sometimes… But I’ll try to be better for you. I love you, Izuku”, her face scrunched up again. Katsuki’s fight or flight instinct was immediately activated. Why couldn’t these people fucking stop crying for one second?

“I love you too, mom”, Izuku sobbed, his words barely understandable. His face was already flooded with tears and snot, and Katsuki turned up his nose in disgust. “I love you”, he sobbed again, hunching over and lowering his head with emotion.

“He’s saying he loves you too”, Katsuki provided simply in between bites, sounding – and looking – increasingly more uncomfortable with that extremely unrelenting emotional moment. In that house with the Midoriyas sobbing like babies at each other, he felt like the odd one out.

“Oh, Izuku”, Inko wailed, covering her face with both hands again as she broke into another sobbing fit. “There’s nothing I want to do more than to give you a hug right now. I wish I could hold you, baby”, she cried, voice muffled by her hands.

Izuku continued to gasp and sob as he fruitlessly attempted to wipe his tears away with the back of his hands. Katsuki stared at him, waiting for him to say something, anything, but he simply continued to sob, eyes squeezed shut. For some reason, Katsuki didn’t feel as sad as he had before… But if Deku was no longer feeling so sad, then why the fuck was he still crying? And why wasn’t Katsuki himself crying either from the emotional bond?

Deku was so fucking confusing and complicated. With each passing day, Katsuki felt like he could simultaneously understand more and less of him. This uncertainty drove him crazy.

“Gave up on trying to hold her back?”, Katsuki asked him simply as he chewed on yet another bite of his katsudon (which, by the way, was delicious, even though it lacked a bit of pepper). He had purposefully kept his tone down, even though he was sure Inko managed to hear his words anyway. Izuku didn’t look at him as he continued to cry.

“I c-can’t”, he sobbed, eyes still squeezed shut. “You *k-know* I can’t, K-Kacchan. And it hurts that I can’t”.

Katsuki fell silent at that, finishing his food. He was done eating the katsudon, whereas Inko hadn't even started hers. She was still sobbing, her face covered away, and Katsuki had no fucking idea what to do. He wasn't exactly a great comforter, and physical touch wasn't really his thing. The idea of giving her a comforting hug and telling her it would be ok did flash across his mind, but it was gone in a second.

He wasn't that kind of person. So he simply stared at the Midoriyas, the both of them crying and sobbing and gasping while Katsuki's eyes darted between them, uncomfortable, at a loss for what to do.

"I'm sorry for this, Katsuki-kun", Inko sniffed finally after a few more moments, wiping her tears away with from her red face with her trembling hands. "It's just… I've been dealing with a lot ever since All Might called, and…", she sighed, her breath coming out shaky and wet and making her sound like she was finally calming down. Katsuki continued to stare at her.

"What did he tell you?", Katsuki asked objectively, not only to ensure that All Might had properly informed Inko of Deku's state, but also to find out whether he had told her more than he had told *him*. He stared at Inko with close attention in his impassive eyes.

"W-Well", she said shakily, still wiping her tears away. "He told me about why they truly kept me from visiting. About Izuku's f-fragile state, and… I was so angry", she sniffed, shaking her head and setting her hands down on the table in the form of fists. She wasn't looking at Katsuki as she spoke, bitterness overtaking her moist face. "I told All Might they couldn't have done that, they couldn't have kept a mother away from her son like that, especially in a situation like this, and that they should at least have told me why they had sent me away… All Might agreed with me, of course. Apparently, none of them are happy with this situation, especially him and your teacher, ah, Aizawa…?"

"Yeah", Katsuki confirmed.

"But apparently, from what All Might told me, Izuku's health state is somewhat… Confidential", she sighed again. Katsuki's ears perked up with attention and he straightened himself on his seat, at the same time Izuku finally lifted his head to look at his mother again. "He… He said the villain who did this to my Izuku has a parasitic quirk".

Katsuki and Izuku exchanged a wary look at the exact same moment, concern etched evidently in both crimson and green.

"… And, because of this, he could still be looking for Izuku, since his quirk hit him… All Might didn't give me too many details, because they can't risk the information leaking out for Izuku's safety. This is another reason why they kept me from visiting – they really are placing Izuku under top security. They – they believe that the villain might be –", she hesitated with another wet sigh, looking like she was about to cry again. "He might be withering away at the same pace as my Izuku. And if that's the case, the only way he might save himself is – is –"

"Getting me back", Izuku completed, but only Katsuki could hear it. He turned to look at the boy, who had a very serious look on his face. "It – it makes sense", he continued, eyes darting

away from Katsuki. “If his quirk is to detach the souls of his victims from their bodies, it would only make sense that the detached soul would end up bound to his”.

“But yours didn’t”, Katsuki noted, something inside his chest squeezing dangerously.

“No, it didn’t. And, if the teachers’ theory is true and he’s also withering away because he doesn’t have my soul –“

“He is probably looking for you”.

Izuku nodded solemnly.

Katsuki lowering his head, trying to put his thoughts in order. The story made sense, but there were also several loopholes in it. If this guy really was hunting for Deku’s soul, then UA’s top priority should be to secure Katsuki, not Deku’s body. Katsuki was the one who had the soul.

Except UA hadn’t released that information to the public. They had only said Izuku was in a coma, so maybe the villain thought Deku’s soul was still in his body.

But if that was the case, why had UA been so quick to tell everyone about Deku’s soul being bound to Katsuki’s? Aizawa and All Might had told Class 1-A all about it as soon as Katsuki found out about it. They had let him tell Inko without batting a fucking eye. If the priority was securing Deku’s soul, why tell about the soul binding to everyone so quickly but hide Deku’s body away and lie about it for so long?

Katsuki thought back to the day he woke up from his concussion and found out he was the only one who could see Deku. He hadn’t given UA much chance to process that information or make it confidential as he burst into Deku’s hospital room and shouted everything at Inko and All Might’s face…

But telling Class 1-A about it didn’t make any sense. Katsuki supposed they only did it so that his friends wouldn’t think Katsuki had gone batshit crazy, talking to himself and beating the shit out of thin air, but still. It had been too risky to tell everyone. It had been too reckless.

And it didn’t really add up.

There was something else to this story, he was sure of it. Something All Might hadn’t told Inko and him. Some information missing, the final piece to the puzzle. Something that would explain why the fuck UA had gone such a long way to protect Deku’s body, which was strategically useless, but shouted information about his soul, which was what the villain wanted, to the seven winds.

Katsuki looked at Deku again. His eyes were distant and unfocused, albeit concentrated, as he held a hand to his chin and muttered to himself, too lost in deep thought and theories to notice Katsuki’s intense gaze. Inko, however, had her big, expressive, green eyes glued on him, her fingers playing nervously with the hem of her skirt as she waited for a response. She had only heard Katsuki’s side of the brief conversation he had just shared with Deku, and hearing confirmation that the villain was looking for her son probably made her even more anxious. Taking a deep breath and mustering all the patience he possibly could into his body

– which, admittedly, wasn't much –, Katsuki turned to her again, trying to figure out what the hell he could possibly say to at least offer this woman some resemblance to comfort.

"Still", Katsuki crossed his arms above his chest and didn't meet her eyes. "They shouldn't have kept you from visiting. You're still his mother, no matter how fucked up Deku is right now".

Ok, not a great comfort, but it was better than sitting in silence, right?

Inko looked even more concerned at the words, but lowered her head and bit her lower lip as she took in Katsuki's words. After a few moments, she tilted her chin up, eyeing Katsuki with… gratitude? He honestly couldn't figure out a single fucking thing about anyone in this fucking family. It felt like the Midoriyas had been especially design to fuck him up and confuse the shit out of him.

"Thank you, Katsuki-kun", she said sincerely, much to Katsuki's increasing sense of confusion. "For speaking up on my behalf", she explained upon his completely lost look. "If it hadn't been for you, I'd… I'd still be in the dark", she reached out across the table and grabbed one of his hands, squeezing it. Katsuki tried to pretend he wasn't extremely uncomfortable by that, and allowed his limp hand to be grabbed by the desperate mother in front of him.

"It's ok", Katsuki said simply, awkward, grumpy, and angry (as always), all at the same time. He didn't look at her and chose to glare at the back of her sofa instead. "I couldn't find out much, but I figured you should know about the shit that's going on".

"And I am very grateful that you felt that way", Inko said again, and Katsuki wished she would stop fucking doing that. After everything he had done to Deku – after her weird, messed up threats on the last time he visited – after her fucking son got half-killed just to save *him*, she had nothing to thank him for. *Nothing*.

Instead of offering a response, he simply grunted, still not meeting her eyes. Her hand holding his was causing such repulse on him. He didn't know why. He wasn't used to that sort of affectionate touch, and her constant gratitude and tears made him nervous. He wanted to get away. He needed to get away. He removed his hand from hers and continued sitting by the dining table, not looking at her or at Deku.

Inko was silent for a while, and Katsuki could feel her eyes on him. Eventually, in silence, she stood up from the table and took his bowl to the kitchen in order to wash it. Her own katsudon was still untouched in front of her empty seat.

Katsuki turned his head to look as she put her apron on. He looked at her own bowl of katsudon, which was still fuming, and then at Deku, who was also staring at Inko with worry in his eyes. He sighed.

"Stay there", he instructed Deku simply, before standing up and walking over to the kitchen. The bags beneath Inko's eyes were dark and heavy. She looked up at him in silent surprise, not having expected him to follow her.

“You didn’t eat your katsudon”, he accused. She frowned for a split second, as if she didn’t even remember she was supposed to eat it, before offering him a forced smile.

“It’s ok”, she nodded. “I’ll eat it in a minute”.

“Go eat it now”, Katsuki added, a bit more harshly than he had intended. His tone may have come off as disrespectful, but he couldn’t bring himself to care. Inko stared at him.

“Katsuki-kun –“

“I can wash it. Go eat with Deku”, he nodded at the table.

Inko lowered her head, looking conflicted.

“You’re my guest –“

“I’m also the guy who beat your son up for years on a roll”.

Inko stared up at him for several moments, the conflict in her eyes increasing. She looked angry, but also embarrassed.

“D-Doing the dishes for me –“

“Won’t erase the fact that I bullied him. I fucking know that”, he took the sponge from her hand abruptly and basically shoved her to the side as gently as he possibly could as he stepped in front of the sink, not looking at her. “That’s not why I’m doing it”.

“Why, then?”, Inko frowned.

“Because you’ve lost weight and you look like you haven’t slept in fucking days”, he said as he scrubbed the bowl with the sponge with more force than necessary. Then, he turned to give her a stern look. “Also because the last thing Deku needs right now is to watch his mom pass out in front of him”, he added, a silent warning in his eyes.

Inko lowered her head, ashamed.

“Still – it’s – it’s not right, you’re my guest –“

“What the hell does that matter?”, he placed the sponge down on the sink with force, making a squishy wet sound. “My hands won’t fall off for washing a fucking bowl and a couple of trays. Also, Deku is looking at you with those ridiculous puppy eyes from the table”, he pointed a soap-covered hand at where Izuku was staring at them. “So go keep him company and eat your food before you keel over”.

Katsuki knew he was probably crossing a line by using that bossy tone with someone older than him, but he was past beyond caring. He could feel Inko’s eyes glued to him, but didn’t look at her as he continued to do the dishes.

“B-But how can I know he’s hearing what I say?”, she asked hesitantly, sounding nervous. Katsuki scowled at her as if that was the most ridiculous question he’d ever heard in his life.

“He can always hear you”, Katsuki told her. “You’re the one who can’t hear him”.

For some reason, Katsuki’s own words made his skin tingle.

That was true for him as well, right? Deku had been with beside him all his life, but he was only now starting to listen to him, over a decade later.

Funny how Deku had always been a ghost to Katsuki and, only now, only when he was *actually* a ghost, could Katsuki see him for real.

“Just fucking talk to him the same way you would have talked if you could actually see him”, he added, going back to avoiding her eyes. “He likes it when people acknowledge him, even though he’s invisible”, he remembered the way Deku had reacted to Icy Hot addressing him directly, instead of using Katsuki as a medium.

Icy Hot had been the only person to do that so far, and Katsuki could feel just how *glad* Deku was that he did. The memory stirred a fresh wave of anger inside him, and Katsuki tightened his grip on the sponge in his hand. Inko, unaware of the reaction, nodded her head in comprehension and removed her apron, handing it over to Katsuki.

“I don’t want your shirt to get wet”, she explained simply. Katsuki grabbed the apron from her hands and put it on, not even caring about Deku seeing him wearing it. He was used to doing the cooking and the dishes around at his house, and he always wore an apron when he did – it was no big deal. Also, if Deku knew what was good for him, he wouldn’t comment on it. *Ever*.

Just for safe keeping, Katsuki looked over Inko’s shoulders and sent Deku, who was still sitting by the dining table and listening to their conversation, a warning death-glare. Izuku looked away, ears red. He only lifted his head when his mother approached him, clearly having no clue where her son was.

“I-Izuku…”, she said hesitantly, not knowing what to do with her hands. “Do you want to sit with me at the couch?”

“Sure, mom”, Izuku stood up, but his mom, of course, could not see it. Katsuki rolled his eyes, feeling annoyance and rage grown within him for having to act as a fucking narrator.

“He heard you. Just go to the couch already, and take your katsudon”, he said in his bored tone, not looking at her as he scrubbed one of the trays she had used to cook the food. Inko blinked at him with embarrassment, but nodded, looking around her for a moment as if expecting to find Izuku before pushing her chair and heading to the couch, her bowl of katsudon in hands. Izuku followed her closely, sitting right beside her.

She was clearly feeling awkward talking to thin air at first, but after she started speaking, she gained more and more confidence. Izuku listened to her with attention.

Katsuki decided to ignore them.

He focused his whole attention on the dishes at hands, at the bubbles of soap on his forearms, on the greasy grime on the water. He did his best to avert his thoughts as far away from Deku as he possibly could, since thinking about stupid Deku was the one thing he seemed to be doing ever since this whole soul-nightmare began.

But no matter how hard he tried to concentrate on literally anything else, he found that he fucking couldn't. One way or another, his thoughts always ended up heading towards the same path – Deku. After all, he was at Deku's home, Deku's scent was all over the place, and everywhere he looked there was a picture of fucking Deku and his fucking eyes. Katsuki found there was no escape. On the top of all that, he could feel what Deku was feeling, he could hear the sound of his voice as he replied to what his mom was saying even though she couldn't hear him. Katsuki could feel his own chest bubble up with the desire to laugh whenever Inko told something funny to Deku, he could feel the painful twist of his heart every time Deku tried to touch his mom and failed. He could feel all sort of mixed, messed up, confused emotions Deku was feeling, and it was driving him fucking nuts.

But at least – and thank fuck for that – the deep, looming sadness Deku had been feeling ever since the night before was gone, which meant Katsuki's plan had fucking worked. Ironic how he was getting so much better at figuring out ways to make Deku happy, while Deku only seemed to be able to infuriate him more with each passing day.

That wasn't entirely true, though. No matter how angry Kirishima's words had made him, Katsuki had to recognize, even if he would never admit it aloud, that he was, indeed, growing on Deku. Surely, the nerd still made him feel angrier than anybody else seemed to be able to, and Katsuki still felt like punching him every now and then, but there was also… Something else. Not the f-word, never the f-word, but… something. Something different. Something that he had described as non-hate to Kirishima, and something that made even him acknowledge that spending time with Deku wasn't as gruesome as he first thought it would be.

Fuck. Katsuki was getting soft, and he could give himself that luxury. This was obviously a result, as Kirishima had said, of Deku's feelings contaminating him. He was only feeling the f-word for Deku because Deku felt the f-word for him. That was the only possible explanation, and there was no other.

Why else would Katsuki, who had dedicated more than a decade of his life to hating Deku's guts and putting him down, grow to like him so much?

He was so fucking conflicted. He knew he was becoming soft, and that thought infuriated him, and there was nothing he wanted more than to punch Deku's stupid teeth in just to show him that Katsuki wasn't weak, Katsuki wasn't a fucking sentimental asshole like he was, Katsuki wasn't catching fucking feelings for him. But, at the same time, he was painfully aware that if he did that, Deku would be sad, and not only Katsuki would also be sad as a result, but he had promised Inko that he would try his best to make her son's shitty soul as comfortable as he could.

Fucking impasse.

He finished washing the dishes, dried them up and set them into a cabinet that seemed to be the place Inko usually kept them. Removing the apron Inko had lent him, he folded it neatly

and placed it on the top of the sink. His hands were tightened into fists as he all but marched his way to the couch, trying his best to keep his confused, paradoxical mixed feelings about Deku as far away from his mind as possible (at the time being). How the fuck was it possible that he wanted to hurt a person and make them happy at the same time?

Maybe Deku wasn't the only one of them that was fucked up in the head.

"… And she sent you her best, of course. Maybe when you're better, we can all pay her a visit! I'm sure she would love to see you", Inko was telling Deku, not bothering to pretend to look at him anymore. At least, she didn't seem as awkward as she had been before. "Everyone misses you, you know. The neighbors, the lady from the market… The one who always used to give you free chocolate when you were little, remember?", she chuckled sadly, not expecting an answer, since she couldn't hear it. "They're all worried about you, and they're… They're proud of you, too. I remember back when you were at the sports festival, how everyone kept congratulating me for your performance… You really surprised them all", she nodded sadly. "You are so loved, Izuku", she concluded, sniffing. Before she could start crying again, Katsuki cleared his throat and stepped into the scene, staring at Inko and at Izuku, who was sitting beside her with wet eyes.

"I put the trays inside the oven and the dishes in the top cabinet", he announced in a bored voice, his face bearing his usual grumpy expression. "I don't know where you usually keep them".

"Oh, Katsuki-kun!", Inko exclaimed, standing up in surprise. She grabbed one of his hands – *get away get away get away get away* – and led him towards the couch, pushing him into the seat beside her. "I was just telling my Izuku how I wanted to show you something".

"Kacchan, don't let her do this", Izuku immediately protested, looking embarrassed and relieved that now there was someone around that could actually listen to him. "She wants to –"

"Since you liked seeing my Izuku's pictures last time you came over", Inko continued, unaware of her son's increasingly frantic state beside her. "I found these old videos I recorded when he was little. I thought you would be interested in seeing that, too!"

"Nooooo", Izuku wailed, covering his red face with both hands and shrinking into himself beside Inko. Katsuki stared with confusion.

No, he was absolutely *not* interested at all in seeing baby Deku babbling with his stupid big eyes on the TV – he never really have the nerve to deal with children –, and the last thing he needed was to see the both of them as kids and feel even more guilty about the way they grown apart from each other. Deku would certainly feel sad if he started to dwell upon their lost friendship yet fucking again, right? But if Deku was so embarrassed about it, if he was blushing and hiding and looking so desperate about these videos, then maybe there was something he didn't want Katsuki to see. What was the nerd hiding anyway?

Katsuki realized that he wanted to find out.

He gave Inko a bored expression, as if he didn't really care about the videos, lest she notice the second intentions behind his eyes.

"Sure, why not", he shrugged with feigned indifference. Inko smiled and grabbed the remote, which was sitting on the coffee table.

"Kacchan, *no*", Izuku protested vehemently. "You won't even like these videos! It's just me as a baby, and we both know how much you dislike both those things", he said, trying to look at Katsuki from behind his mother's shoulders, since Inko was sitting between them on the couch.

"Sure, Deku", Katsuki said, offering the nerd a vicious smirk. "I'm glad your mom had the idea to pick these videos up, too".

"Oh, so Izuku wants to see them, too!", Inko cheered. "I was afraid he wouldn't like the idea".

"I *don't*!", Izuku protested, his voice raising an octave. "Kacchan, tell her!"

"What are you talking about, he *loves* the idea", Katsuki said instead, leaning back on the couch and placing his feet on the coffee table. Inko gave him a slightly disapproving look at this, but he didn't notice it and she didn't say anything.

"Kacchan, stop! This isn't fair!", Izuku continued to protest, his face looking as red as a tomato. "These videos are embarrassing! And take your feet of the table!"

"Here goes the first one!", Inko announced.

"*What is it, baby?*", the Inko from the video asked.

"*Mighto!*", a three-year-old Izuku replied, wearing what Katsuki assumed to be the All Might Hoodie #2.

"*What is it?*", Inko asked again in a motherly tone, as Izuku reached his chubby hands towards her, asking to be picked up from the ground. The camera shuffled for a bit as Inko held it up with one hand and picked Izuku up with the other. Then, the camera shuffled again as she turned it around in order to face them, recording them in selfie-mode.

"*Mighto Mighto Mighto!*", Izuku exclaimed happily, waving his hands frantically.

"*You want to see All Might again?"*

"Miiiiiiiiiiiighto!!!"

"But you've already seen All Might five times today, honey!", she jostled him in order to adjust his weight in her arms.

"*Mighto! Mighto!"*

"All right, let's see him again!"

“Yaaaaaay!”

“But then no more for today, all right, honey?”

“Nooooo! All Mighto!”

“Here you go, sweetheart”

Inko placed the tiny Izuku on a rolling chair in front of the open laptop and played the video of the All Might rescue. Izuku cheered madly, waving his arms around in excitement. The scene was cut off, and a new video immediately started.

“This was when the All Might phase started”, Inko explained to Katsuki as a grassy field appeared on the next footage. “It never really ended, right, Izuku?”, she teased, but there was no malice in her tone.

“Mooooom”, Izuku groaned beside her, his face still red. His knees were pulled up to his chest.

“*Is that your quirk?*”, the Inko in the video asked, chuckling, filming a 5-year-old Izuku playing by himself in a garden. He had a stick on his hand, and he was waving it around madly.

“*No! It’s my sword!”,* baby Izuku explained, not looking at his mom as he continued to wave the stick around.

“*Oooh, what a nice sword you have, Izuku!”*

“I’m a hero!”

“Yes, you are, honey!”

“My quirk is making the sword fly wherever I want to!”

“Really?! Let mom see!”

Izuku sent the stick flying away several meters.

“*How impressive! And how do you get the sword back?”*

“I have to go and pick it up!”

And then he started running, picked the stick up, and came back laughing.

“*I’m a hero! I will save you from the monsters!”*

“Ahh! The monsters!”, Inko exclaimed in a pretend-scared voice. “*Save me, Mighty Boy!”*

“I’ll save you, mommy!”, Izuku started to wave the stick around again, pretending to fight invisible monsters. The video ended with both Inko and Izuku laughing together, and a new one started.

"*It's ok, honey, try again".*

"No!"

"I know you can do it, dear. Come on!", she encouraged.

"*No! He'll just mock me again!".*

"I'm sure he won't. Come on, say it with mom".

Izuku stared up at him with uncertain eyes.

"*Ka…",* Inko encouraged. Izuku hesitated.

"*Ka…"*, he complied.

"*Now's the tricky part… Tsu…"*

Izuku's baby face scrunched up in concentration.

"*Tchu".*

"Tsu".

"Tchu!"

"Tssssu"

"Tchuuuu!"

"It's ok, honey. You just need a bit more practice".

"Katchuki!"

"You're almost there. Say it with mom: Katsuki".

"Katchuki!"

"With an 's' sound, baby. Like in katsudon".

"Katsudon!"

"Yes, baby, that's it! You say 'Katsuki' just like 'katsudon'".

"Katchuki".

"With an 's', baby".

"Katchuki!"

"Just like 'katsudon', honey. You can do it".

"Ka…tchuki"

Baby Izuku huffed out a breath in frustration, looking angry and disappointed at himself.

"*It's ok, Izuku. You'll get it right with time, don't worry. Why don't you keep calling him 'Kacchan' until then?"*

"Ok! I like 'Kacchan' better!"

Katsuki turned on his seat to look at Izuku with incredulity written all over his face. Izuku, as he expected, was not looking at him, his red face buried between his knees.

"*Is it on?",* Katsuki heard his own voice say, and turned back towards the TV. There he was, as a kid, standing beside a beaming-with-happiness Izuku. They must have been around 5 or 6 years old at that time.

"*Yes! Go ahead!",* Inko replied.

"*I… I don't know if I got it right…",* child Izuku protested, looking hesitant all of a sudden. Katsuki rolled his eyes and nudged him with his elbow.

"*Come on, Izuku. We trained this like a hundred times".*

"Kacchan…"

"Just do it. Let's go".

Before waiting for Izuku to get ready, Katsuki started to do the All Might choreography. Izuku only hesitated for a few seconds before following him. Together, they danced and sang along to the All Might theme that was popular at the time, performing it perfectly (even if Izuku was a bit delayed, mostly copying Katsuki's steps a split second after he'd made them).

"*Wohoo! You guys are amazing! You should get the All Might prize for best dancers in Japan!",* Inko exclaimed in support.

"Don't be silly, kids can't participate on that contest", Katsuki replied obnoxiously, in that petulant, know-it-all tone that was still characteristic to him to this day. Inko seemed unbothered, probably reading it as a child's behavior.

"*But you're so good you could do it!"*

"Yeah, I guess you're right", Katsuki shrugged, walking away.

"*Wait, Kacchan!",* Izuku trailed after him, as always.

"Ah, you haven't changed a bit", Inko commented, focused on the screen. When the next video came up, Katsuki's attention faltered as Inko's words sunk into his brain.

Had he really not changed one bit? Seeing himself on the video – the way he talked to Deku's mom, who had only ever been extremely caring and polite to him – he realized that he was

more of an asshole than he remembered being. Sure, he knew he'd been an asshole, if Deku's moaning and complaining over the course of the time they'd been together was anything to go by, but still… He had thought he'd gotten better after he was accepted into UA. Hell, he had thought he'd gotten better after the All Might thing, after his fight with Deku, after being glued to Deku and trying to be nicer to him. Had he really not changed *one bit*? Had he really not improved at all? Was he still the same annoying, obnoxious kid who thought he knew better than anyone? Was he still a rude, disrespectful asshole that walked away unannounced and expected people to just follow him?

Had he not changed one bit?

Was that why Deku was still so sad all the time? Because, no matter how hard Katsuki tried to be better, he couldn't? Was he really that weak, to the point of being unable to change himself into someone who wasn't absolutely despicable? Was he really that helpless? That much of a failure?

What kind of hero – hell, what kind of *man* – did he expect to be if he couldn't do something as simple as acknowledging his flaws and improving himself? What kind of fucking hero would he be if he was unable to improve himself?

Maybe that was why Deku had surpassed him so fast. Deku, the weak, pathetic, useless wimp who used to lick Katsuki's boots, and who was now stronger than him. Deku, who met All Might on the same day as Katsuki, and who had been chosen to inherit the number one hero's power. Deku, who had been nothing, *nothing*, and who still managed to achieve the same as Katsuki with less means. Deku, who only inherited All Might's quirk because Katsuki had been weak, and was still weak, and would always be weak, no matter how hard he fucking tried to be strong. Because he was trying to be better, but he *hadn't changed a bit*, right? And this could only mean that, no matter how hard he tried to become stronger, he would fail. He was a failure. He was a *fucking failure*.

"I – I think that's enough videos for today, right?", Inko said hesitantly, and only then Katsuki realized that his hands were tightened into fists and there was smoke coming from them as he got lost in deep thought. Behind Inko, Izuku was staring at him with a deeply concerned look, even though his face was still reddish from embarrassment.

Inko turned the TV off and shifted on the couch to look at Katsuki, who was avoiding her eyes in embarrassment for losing control so easily – *weak* – and who was trying his best to calm himself. He could feel Deku trying to help him, trying to overwhelm himself with calmness so that some of it would seep into Katsuki, but this only served to infuriate him even more. He didn't fucking need Deku's goddamn help, and he hadn't fucking asked for it.

"Katsuki-kun… Are you ok?", Inko asked, reaching to touch his hand. Katsuki immediately flinched away from the touch. He didn't want it. He didn't need it.

Fuck, he just needed some peace. He needed some time off.

"I'm fine", he grunted, not looking at her. Deku stood up from his seat and walked over to Katsuki, crouching in front of him, the little shit.

“Kacchan”, Deku said, clearly worried. “Do you want to leave?”

“I’m – I’m sorry if I made you uncomfortable”, Inko said, retrieving her hand with embarrassment. “I thought you would like to watch the videos –“

“It’s *fine*”, he repeated, a bit more harshly than necessary. In all honesty, he was just angry at himself. For everything. Inko frowned at him.

“Y-You…”, she hesitated, looking conflicted. Then she pursed her lips and tilted her chin up, looking like she was mustering all it took her to be brave and speak her mind. “You don’t look fine, Katsuki-kun”, she said in a firm voice. “Are you sure you don’t want to talk about it?”

Talk about fucking *what*? About how weak he was? About how her stupidly weak son had managed to surpass him, even though Katsuki had been training hard his whole life? About how he was unable to improve as a person, as a man, as a hero, no matter how hard he tried? What *exactly* could he fucking say to her? And why the fuck was he about to break the fuck down at Inko Midoriya’s house, just because he’d watched some shitty video of his childhood with Deku? Just because she’d make a comment that made him uncomfortable? Why the fuck was this shit affecting so much? And why the fuck couldn’t he control it?

This had to be Deku’s fault, he figured. Katsuki had never been such an emotional person, he’d always been able to control himself and his anger and his quirk. This was happening because Deku couldn’t control his fucking overwhelming feelings, it had to be, and he was flooding Katsuki with sadness and anxiety and love and misery and longing and everything, all the things he never learned how to deal with before. All the stuff he internalized, all the stuff he buried deep inside himself in order not to deal with them. And now Deku was making him feel everything. He was making him feel every fucking thing all the fucking time, and he was tired, and he wanted to have some privacy and some time for himself, and he wanted a fucking break from feeling so much at the same time, because he was sure, he was fucking sure, no matter how much he hated it, that not everything he was feeling was coming from Deku. Some of that stuff was coming from himself, and it fucking terrified him, and it fucking made him *angry*.

He was probably losing it harder than he thought he was, because Inko broke right into his personal space (so *that* was where Deku got it from) and pulled Katsuki into a tight, motherly hug to comfort him.

Everything froze.

What Katsuki felt was beyond description.

His mother loved him; he had no doubt of that. But, just like Katsuki, she had a tremendous difficulty in showing affection. His dad, too, was too awkward to do so properly, so all he ever received growing up were awkward pats on the back and a few pinches on his cheek. His mom found other ways to show him she cared – calling him ‘brat’, being stern to him whenever he got too cocky, talking wonders of him to other people in his ear range, just so he’d know how much she admired him. So, other than millions of other parental problems he faced during his childhood, receiving and giving physical affection was just one of them. He

never learned how to do it, which was probably why he had such a hard time communicating with Deku. If Deku had such a loving mom, such an attentive mom, he probably expected Katsuki to behave the same way towards him. And Katsuki hadn't been raised like that. He didn't *know* how to do that. The way he had learned how to show affection was through yelling, and slapping, and calling names, and criticizing people in order to make them grow. His mom had done that. Once she realized Katsuki's head had grown too much… She tried to help him be better. By *telling him everything he was doing wrong*.

It was like breaking bones to make them stronger.

Comprehensively, Katsuki sucked at the emotional field. He knew it was his parents' fault (wasn't everything?), but he also knew they weren't to blame. They loved him, and they did their best. But once they realized they had fucked up, it was already too late.

And Katsuki… Katsuki had never been hugged like that by his mother. Surely, his mother hugged him, and cared for him, and loved him, but this… This was different. This was a motherly hug. This was… This was…

Too fucking much. Not only because of the touch starvation he had grown used to throughout his life, without even realizing it was there, but because Deku could feel it too. He didn't know how, but he just knew Deku could feel it too. And his happiness – his relief, his comfort, everything – was way too fucking overwhelming. Way too fucking overwhelming.

Katsuki did his best to hold back a sob, and Inko felt as he began to shake. Her hold on him tightened, which made Deku's feelings more intense, which on its own term made Katsuki feel like he was about to explode (literally). He was feeling way too much. It was like his skin was on fire, sparkling with electricity.

He felt… loved.

"K-K-Kacchan", Deku tried to say, probably trying to tell him that he could feel his mother's hug. Katsuki simply drew in a shaky breath, trying not to scream and sob all at the same time while Inko still held him.

"I know, Deku", he said simply, his voice shaky and muffled by Inko's shoulder.

"Y-You… D-Do?", Deku asked, frowning. Katsuki could see him from the top of Inko's shoulder, where his face was buried, and he hated the fact that Deku could probably see the involuntary tears that were pooling in his eyes. He didn't want to fucking cry, but it was hard not to when Deku's feelings were breaking into him like a broken dam.

(He knew that the tears in his eyes were also due to the overwhelming sensation of having someone hug him like that for the first time ever, but he decided to shove that into the list of "things I don't want to think about" for the time being).

Inko suddenly broke away from the hug, as if realizing she had overstepped a boundary. She stared at Katsuki with apologetic eyes, looking as if she had just been burned. The guilt on her face increased when she noticed the teary look in Katsuki's face.

“I’m – I’m sorry”, she said, hesitant and looking at a loss for what to do. “I didn’t mean to – I didn’t – It’s just –“, she took in a deep breath, allowing her hands to fall on her lap. She gave Katsuki a sad look. “You looked like you could use a hug”, she justified.

Katsuki didn’t know what the fuck to say to that.

You looked like you were asking for help…

Fuck the fucking Midoriyas to fucking hell.

“I’m sorry if I made you uncomfortable –“, Inko continued, but Katsuki didn’t want to fucking hear whatever it was she was about to say next, so he interrupted with the only thing that came to mind:

“Deku could feel it”.

There was a pregnant pause.

“… W-What?”, Inko asked, confused.

Katsuki didn’t look at her, or at Deku, as he continued, head bowed and face painted with anger and unshed tears that were making his crimson eyes glisten.

“He could feel your hug”.

Inko continued to stare at him. So did Deku.

“Kacchan…”, Deku said after a while. Katsuki couldn’t figure out if that thing making his voice wobbly was gratitude, or surprise, or sadness, or all of those.

“He… could?”, Inko asked, sounding like she was about to cry again. Katsuki couldn’t look at her. Not at her teary eyes. Not after she’d… hugged him like that. Like he was a fragile child in need of comfort.

In many ways, wasn’t he?

Inko shifted on the couch, getting closer to Katsuki. Every fiber of his being was screaming at him to get away from her touch, because it was fucking scary, but he didn’t. He found that he didn’t want to.

“Can I…”, Inko started, sounding awkward. Katsuki still wasn’t meeting her eyes. “Can I hug you again? Properly, this time?”

Katsuki bit his lower lip, his head bowed. He found himself nodding, despite of his brain screaming at him to get the fuck away.

Katsuki loved his mom. The old hag knew the perfect way to infuriate him, and they fought all the time, and sometimes, after particularly vicious arguments, he felt like leaving and never looking at Mitsuki Bakugou ever again, but he couldn’t deny that he loved her. She cooked him the best spicy food, she knew the best way to put him back in line, she knew the

best way to praise him. She gave his hair the best cuts, she made him the best silly puns, she gave him the best care whenever he was sick. Surely, she and his dad had made some mistakes in raising him… But they loved him, and he loved them.

But, as it was with every parent, there were some things they just weren't any good at. Things they couldn't give him. Things they couldn't teach him, no matter how perfect Katsuki used to think they were when he was a kid. And being affectionate… Being emotionally stable. His parents didn't know how to teach him that. His mom was too explosive, his dad was too lenient. There wasn't a middle-ground. There wasn't a balance.

As Inko Midoriya held him close and gently stroked his hair in a way that could only be described as motherly… Katsuki found that he felt uncharacteristically balanced. As if she was taking part of his burden. As if she didn't want him to carry it alone. And yes, having such a close contact after years of never hugging anyone was overwhelming as fuck, but it was also… Relaxing.

For some reason, it made him feel safe. It made him feel like he could put his guard down, like he could finally allow himself to take a break and not worry about being defensive, even if only for a minute.

He found himself relaxing and sinking into Inko's arms. He was feeling embarrassed by it and he would probably never be able to look her in the eyes again, but the way her fingers were gently caressing his scalp was so soothing that Katsuki didn't find the mind to care about that just then.

He knew very well that she hadn't forgiven him entirely for what he had done to Deku throughout their lives. Katsuki still had a long way to go if he wanted her to forgive him… and he found himself surprised to realize that he did, in fact, wish that she'd forgive him someday.

Huh. Maybe she had been wrong. Maybe he *was* changing.

Maybe the process was just too slow for anyone to notice yet.

And maybe it was just too hard to admit he wanted to be better.

"So".

Silence.

“Are we going to talk about it?”

“No”.

“Why?”

“Because there’s nothing to talk about”.

“Uh, I think there is”.

“Think again, loser”.

A sigh.

“I still think there is”.

“You’re fucking wrong”.

“You just hugged my mom for five minutes straight and then left the apartment without saying anything”.

“So fucking what?”

“It was weird. She’ll probably think she weirded you out”.

“See if I give a fuck”.

“I think you do”.

“I also don’t give a fuck about what you think”.

Another sigh.

“Can we please talk about this? *Please*?”

“You wanna talk about it?”

“Yes, Kacchan”.

“Fine. Call me by my first name, then”.

An awkward pause.

“Seriously?”

“Yeah. I’m serious as hell”.

“I want to talk about the hug –“

“And I want to talk about me”.

“As usual”.

“Shut the fuck up and go ahead. Say it”.

“No”.

“It’s simple, Deku. Just say it. *Katsuki*”.

“No!”

“You can’t, can you?”

“Stop it”.

“No”.

“You’re being childish”.

“So are you, since you can’t say something as simple as *Katsuki*”.

“Don’t mock me about it!”

“Why not? It’s funny as fuck”.

“Stop it! It’s not!”

“Is that why you still call me Kacchan?”

Silence.

“Oh my fucking god. It *is*”.

Izuku turned his head away so that he would face the car’s window, rather than Katsuki, even though he was nestled against the boy’s chest (only so that he wouldn’t phase right out of the car. Only because of that, of course).

“And here I thought for all those years that you were patronizing me. Turns out you’re just dumb”.

Izuku turned his head towards Katsuki again, indignation written all over his face.

“I'm not dumb!”

A scornful scoff.

"Yeah, sure, Deku".

Izuku went silent, adjusting himself against Katsuki and refusing to look at him. However, Katsuki could tell that he wasn't sad or upset, for once; if anything, his feelings were unusually balanced. Maybe paying Inko that visit and going through all that emotional crap

had paid off, because, for the first time in *days*, Katsuki didn't feel like his chest was about to collapse on itself.

He didn't want to think about what that meant, or why being hugged by Deku's mother had felt so surprisingly comforting. If anything, Katsuki hadn't realized he was in such a need for a real hug until he received one.

Kirishima was the only person who had the guts to attempt something close to a hug with Katsuki, but it often didn't go beyond an arm around his shoulders pulling him close, or a quick, too-fast-to-count chest-to-chest embrace. Inko, on the other hand, had enveloped Katsuki in her arms and held him, as if she actually cared about him. As if she wanted to lessen his burden, share the weight with Katsuki. And, for the first time in his life, in an unprecedented way, Katsuki didn't feel bothered out of his fucking mind about someone wanting to help him.

He wished he could explain or understand why.

The rest of the car ride back to UA was silent, since their escort knew better than to attempt small talk with Katsuki and Deku was still pretending to be offended. Katsuki spent the time in silence staring out the window on his side, doing his best to ignore several things: 1. the way Inko had hugged him; 2. the way the hug had made him feel so much better, and as a consequence made Deku feel better as well; 3. the way Deku's curls were tickling his chin, since the boy's head was resting between his collarbone and his neck as Katsuki held him close to prevent him from being catapulted off the car; 4. the weird f-word feeling that he had felt while watching a baby Deku attempt to say his name properly and failing.

Katsuki never wanted to watch that sort of video again, not only because they clearly made Deku nostalgic (and therefore sad) as shit, but because Katsuki himself always ended up feeling a series of confusing emotions whenever he did.

He didn't want to fucking think about it. He was too wary of the possible conclusion he would end up reaching if he did. And the stuff those videos made him feel - the stuff *Deku* was starting to make him feel - was a territory he didn't want to tread in.

He was supposed to hate Deku, right? Or, at the very least, they were supposed to be proper rivals, now. Katsuki wasn't supposed to feel *anything* else for him. Being together with Deku was the fucking annoying result of a villain's quirk; spending time with him shouldn't be something enjoyable. Katsuki wasn't supposed to fucking like him, or to feel sympathy for him, or to feel *anything* other than pure, unrivaled contempt.

But no matter how hard he tried to stop himself, he couldn't fucking help but to, at the very least, empathize with Deku at some level.

Kirishima had to be right. These weird feelings had to be a mirror of Deku's, and nothing else, because there was no way in hell Katsuki actually *liked* Deku now, after all those years of hatred and anger and bullying, right?

Right?

Fucking *hell*.

Katsuki supposed the only way to find that out was to break that annoying-as-fuck bond he was sharing with Deku and see if the f-word he was feeling for the nerd would linger or would go away along with his shitty soul.

Katsuki hoped the feeling would disappear, because if it didn't – if it lingered, even after Deku was no longer attached to him – he had no fucking clue what that would mean, or what he would do about it.

It was easier to convince himself that what he felt was just a mirror of Deku's feelings, and that was it. It was a simpler explanation, which had a simpler solution than actually having to deal with his emotions.

It was only once they were back inside school grounds, after the car pulled over in front of the dorm building, that Katsuki realized Deku had dozed off in his arms, probably feeling as exhausted as Katsuki felt by the intense emotional toll they had gone through in the past hours (and also in the past day).

Fucking goddamn hell of a motherfucking piece of fucking shit of a situation, really.

The driver didn't ask any questions (thankfully) as Katsuki sat there very still and made no move to open the door or exit the car, but he did glance at the boy through the rearview mirror with a curious look on his face. Katsuki, on his own turn, had no fucking idea what he should do to wake Deku up, since he had never been in the sort of situation where someone fell asleep in his arms.

The truth was that, no matter how hard he was trying to be better to Deku and make him happier, not only for the nerd's sake but also for his own, that didn't mean Katsuki was a hypocrite. He wasn't about to go all gentle and touchy-feely on the nerd just because he wanted to be a better person, or because he cared a little bit about Deku now. There were some things Katsuki simply couldn't change about himself, due to several different, complex reasons, and the last thing he needed was for Deku to think that Katsuki was getting *soft*.

Because of this, Katsuki unceremoniously removed his arm from where it was supporting Deku's weight, making the boy jostle back into awareness with a surprised gasp at the sudden absence of a support for his head and back. Pretending he hadn't noticed Deku's clear embarrassment for having fallen asleep on him, Katsuki grabbed the bag with the Crimson Riot plush he had gotten Kirishima and opened the car's door, stepping out and holding it open for Deku without meeting his eyes. Deku meekly dragged himself towards the door and stepped out of the car as well, standing beside him awkwardly. Katsuki could tell, from his peripheral vision, that Deku was also avoiding looking at him.

Katsuki was ok with that accidental nap being the sort of shit they never talked about again.

They made the way back to Katsuki's room in silence, walked inside in silence. Katsuki went to the bathroom in silence and came out to find Deku sitting on his bed in silence. He spared the boy a quick glance before going on about his business, sitting by his studying desk and

turning his laptop on. Just when he was starting to think that Deku was too much of a coward to speak up and diffuse the tension in the room, the nerd sighed loudly and broke the silence.

"Can we talk about it now?"

Katsuki made sure Deku could see how hard he was rolling his eyes and how grumpy his face looked before replying without looking at him.

"Why the fuck can't you just drop this fucking subject?"

Deku lowered his eyes, suddenly embarrassed and way too hesitant for someone who had sounded so certain a moment before.

"Is…", he started, swallowing dry and not looking at Katsuki. "Do you want me to drop this subject because it's something sensitive to you, or are you just trying to make me shut up?"

Katsuki rolled on his chair so that he could stare straight at Deku, fury glistening in his crimson eyes.

"When you look at my fucking face, is the word 'sensitive' the first damn thing that comes to your mind?"

Deku closed his eyes and tried to pretend he wasn't rolling them beneath his eyelids.

"No, Kacchan, but -"

"Then yeah, I'm just trying to make you shut the hell up, but as usual you're not complying", he turned back towards his desk. Deku, however, didn't give up so easily.

"I asked you because you complained that I can never tell when you don't want to talk about something, and that I keep insisting, so I figured it would be better to ask you about it first", he explained, a bit too defensively.

"Not wanting to talk about shit doesn't mean I'm fucking sensitive about it", Katsuki retorted effortlessly, typing down on his laptop.

"Then why don't you want to talk about the hug?"

"Because, as I've said over and over again and you are apparently too thick in the fucking head to understand, there's nothing to talk about", he growled through gritted teeth, annoyed. "It was just a fucking hug. There's nothing to it".

"I don't think so".

"And, as I've also said over and over again, I don't give a shit about what you think".

"But I give a shit about what you feel".

Katsuki's heart capsized painfully at the words, panic immediately flooding his veins. What the fuck was that about?!?!? Did Deku know about his confusing feelings? Could he figure

them out in a way that Katsuki couldn't? Could he decipher them in a way Katsuki himself did not want to?

Fuck fuck fuck. He couldn't show weakness or fear - he couldn't let Deku feel his weakness and his fear. Instead of allowing himself to be overtaken by the adrenaline in his veins, and before Deku could end up mimicking his emotions, Katsuki tilted his head to the side in order to face the boy, who was sitting cross-legged in front of him on the bed, and glared daggers at him as a way to hide his panic. Katsuki hoped the look would be enough to intimidate the little shit, as it had never failed to do so in the past, but the nerd, on his turn, tilted his chin up in defiance in a way that much resembled his mom, unfaltering beneath Katsuki's death stare.

"I could feel your emotions, Kacchan", he continued, firm, and holy fuck, Katsuki did NOT want to have this conversation. He thought about running out the door, or exploding his window and jumping off, but all those options would inevitably result in Deku's soul being dragged right behind him. "And I know this wasn't just any hug", Deku continued. "I don't know why, and it's ok if you don't want to tell me why, but I could feel how… shaken you were by it".

Katsuki continued to glare at Deku, hating him more than ever. Couldn't he fucking see that Katsuki didn't want to talk about this? Couldn't he realize that Katsuki would rather jump off his fucking window than try to understand and acknowledge his own damn feelings?

"Kacchan…", Izuku continued, sounding weirdly worried now. He shifted on the bed, looking like he wanted to approach Katsuki or perhaps even touch him, but lacked the courage to do so. Maybe he was just trying to respect Katsuki's personal space for the first time fucking ever. "Have you… Did you…"

"You know I fucking hate it when you stutter like that", Katsuki cut him off, furious. His hands were already balled into fists. "Don't fucking start talking unless you have something to say".

"S-Sorry", Izuku apologized, sounding sincere. "It's just --"

"It's just what?", he interrupted again, feeling way angrier than he should have. Deep down, he knew stupid Deku was just worried about him, but Katsuki just couldn't help but to hear a patronizing tone in Deku's voice that wasn't actually there, and having to talk about feelings, on the top of having to feel them, was way more than he had signed up to. "You think you know any fucking thing about me just because you can feel what I feel? Just because we have a shitty empathic bond that drains us the fuck out more often than it's fucking tolerable? You think you know any fucking thing about me just because you decided to trail after me when you were a brat and you haven't stopped ever since? Is that what you think?", he ended up shouting, standing up from his chair and panting at Deku, who was staring at him from the bed with wide eyes.

However, Katsuki didn't feel sad. He didn't feel any hurt, as he should have, because his shouting and his words were bound to make Deku feel all miserable again, right? Besides his anger, and his discomfort with that subject, and that unnamable thing that was twisting his insides ever since Inko Midoriya put her fucking arms around him, Katsuki wasn't feeling anything. There was nothing coming from Deku other than a deep, constant sense of concern,

and worry, and protectiveness, and that knowledge only infuriated Katsuki further. He didn't need Deku to fucking protect him from any fucking thing.

And yet… Deku kept saving him in so many different ways, so many different times.

Katsuki cursed himself for being so weak. He hated himself for being so pathetic, to the point of needing a fuckhead such as Deku to save him. First, from the sludge monster, and now from this fucking villain…

Katsuki wanted to scream. He wanted to tear his room to pieces in anger at himself. He wanted to let out everything he was feeling, tear everything out of his body, get rid of all that overwhelming, suffocating shit he had no idea how do deal with –

Deku threw himself off the bed and onto Katsuki, enveloping him in a tight hug.

Katsuki was way too shocked to have a proper reaction, so he simply stood there, unmoving, both his arms hanging idly at his sides, as Deku clung to him and squeezed him tightly, almost as if he was trying his best to simulate the effect Inko's hug had had on Katsuki. Katsuki couldn't say Deku was succeeding, but he couldn't say he was failing, either.

He couldn't say anything, for that matter.

Deku buried his face against Katsuki's chest and held him close, and honestly, every single fucking fiber of Katsuki's being was screaming at him to get away, to shove Deku away from him, to beat him up for even attempting to hug him in a way that not even Kirishima dared to do, to fuck him up with his fists and his quirk, to teach him a lesson, to make sure he never tried to do something like that ever again.

But, at the same time… He didn't feel anything at all.

It was almost as if…

God, he couldn't comprehend it. He couldn't put it into words. But it felt good. It felt more than good. It felt… It felt…

"I'm sorry", Deku said against his chest, voice muffled. "I should have realized it sooner".

Katsuki wanted to ask what in the goddamn fuck Deku was talking about, but he found that he couldn't. He continued to stand very still, not moving an inch, not even bothering to envelop Deku with his arms. He simply stayed there, unmoving, allowing himself to be hugged, and wondering what the fuck Deku should have realized sooner. What the fuck Deku had realized in the first place.

Upon Katsuki's silence, Deku tilted his head so that he could look at him, his arms still enveloping Katsuki.

"Is this ok?", he asked, sounding like he would genuinely break the hug if Katsuki just said the word. Katsuki just stared down at him, struggling hard to figure out whether he wanted to punch Deku or hug him back. Deku frowned upon a lack of response. "Kacchan? Are you ok?"

Katsuki didn't answer. He didn't know if he was ok. He didn't know anything anymore, and it infuriated him.

This was too much.

He wriggled himself away from Deku's arms and Deku let him go as soon as he sensed resistance coming from Katsuki. He turned his back on Deku and refused to look at him, refused to speak up, refused to do anything other than breathe and blink blankly and try to figure out what the fuck was going on inside him.

"I'm sorry if I made you uncomfortable", Deku said, sounding like he wanted to hug Katsuki again, and the worry irradiating from him was so fucking evident that Katsuki didn't need to be emotionally bound to the nerd to be able to feel it. "It's just – I thought you needed a hug".

Katsuki didn't say anything.

"You – The way you reacted when my mom hugged you, it made me realize".

Realize what? Realize what, shitty Deku? Just speak the fuck up already, stop trying to make me ask it.

"I don't think I remember seeing you hug someone, really hug someone, in all those years we've known each other. And – And I told you before. About the affection thing. You – You don't know how to show it".

Wow, what a fucking goddamn genius you are. Really outstanding, fucking shitty Deku, congratufuckinglations.

"Don't you… Long for it?"

Weird fucking question. I don't fucking like this.

"Because… I mean, one of the things I miss the most about being in my body is… Is being able to touch people a-and… I know this may sound w-w-weird and s-stupid, b-but…"

Just stop stuttering and speak the fuck up goddamn it!

"It's n-n-nice. B-Being able to touch you. Even if… we don't really t-touch much. And I t-think… It might be good for us. Emotionally, I-I m-mean".

What the ever-loving fuck is that supposed to mean?

"I n-never got to know your m-mom much, but… She didn't hug you much, did she?"

Red alert. Red fucking alert. Nope. He wasn't talking about that.

"And I think – you felt so much better after m-my mom hugged you, s-so maybe… If you're ok with it, I c-could – I – I could –"

Deku sounded like he was about to break the fuck down on him, but Katsuki couldn't face him.

"K-Kacchan, can you p-please… Can you turn around?"

Katsuki stayed still.

"It's just… Your silence is scaring me".

Katsuki said nothing.

"You were like this, too. After m-my mom hugged you. And I think you forgot I can feel what you're f-feeling, so please", he grabbed Katsuki's wrist. "I know it upsets you when I'm sad".

It doesn't, you fucking nerd. Shut up.

"And I'm trying to control it better, like y-you're controlling your anger better".

No, you're not.

"And I'm really glad and thankful that you keep trying to make me happy and that you took m-me to see my mom".

Fuck you. I hate you.

"So can you please… Can you let me try to m-make you happy, too?"

I fucking hate you. I want you to fucking die. I hate you so much. I have to hate you. I have to hate you. I have to. I can't just stop hating you out of fucking nowhere, you piece of shit. I can't be weak.

"I don't know how to do it and I'm sorry".

Fuck off.

"But – I want t-to try. I want to help you, Kacchan".

Katsuki yanked his wrist away from Izuku's hold at the words.

"I k-know you don't need my help".

You don't know shit.

"But I'd want to give it t-to you anyway. N-Not because I think you're a charity case, but…"

Why, then, shitty Deku?

"It's…"

Why? Fucking why? Tell me fucking why, I don't know why, I never knew the fuck why, I don't understand why, and I hate this.

For the first time ever, Deku gave up. This was too much for him, too.

"I'll… I'll be here for you if you need me, ok?"

Fuck fuck fuck fuck.

"Sorry if – if I made you uncomfortable. I didn't mean to".

Katsuki tilted his head just the slightest bit, only to see Deku backing away with the most miserable look on his face. A look of defeat, of retreat, of hopelessness. All the fucking progress he had made had just been flushed down the damn toilet. And Katsuki's skin was on fire, his chest was tight with all sorts of paradoxical emotions, and his brain couldn't make sense of a single fucking thing that was happening to him on that fucking day, which was probably why he ended up blurting out:

"Do it again".

Izuku stopped in his tracks, looking at him with surprise.

"W-What?"

Way to fucking go. Now how was he supposed to get out of this shit?

"You fucking heard me, you asshole. I'm not saying it again", was Katsuki's very sensitive response, spat at Izuku through a gritted-teeth growl.

He was doing this for Deku, he convinced himself. Because giving him hugs and that shit would make Deku happy, and he needed Deku to be happy so that he could be happy, and he had made Deku's mom a promise to keep him happy. This had absolutely nothing to do with the fact that being hugged made Katsuki feel horrible and in bliss at the same time, in a way he had never experienced, and it had nothing to do with his own need, or his own happiness, or his own wish to be touched and cared for. He never even fucking knew he had that need until Inko cursed him with that knowledge, which was bestowed upon him by her damn comforting motherly hug.

Izuku crossed the distance between them and looked deep into Katsuki's eyes, as if asking for permission.

"Are you sure?", he asked, nervous.

"If you hesitate one fucking second longer, I'm not letting you put your filthy hands on me ever fucking again", was Katsuki's angry response.

Fine. Here goes nothing.

Izuku sighed and enveloped Katsuki with his arms once more before he could change his mind, this time much gentler than before. He buried his face in Katsuki's chest.

They stayed like that for moments that felt like an eternity, and Katsuki…

Katsuki felt surprisingly ok with that.

“Aren’t you going to hug me back?”, Izuku asked after a while, his voice muffled by Katsuki’s shirt.

“Don’t push your fucking luck”.

“If you didn’t want to, you wouldn’t have held me so close back in the train, or at the car”, Izuku accused, dangerously brave. The fucking nerd’s head was growing too much, and Katsuki wanted to put him back into his place, at the same time that he didn’t.

“It’s like you’re basically begging me to never fucking touch you again in my life”.

“Kacchan. It’s ok”.

Katsuki didn’t move.

“I won’t tell anyone”.

“Oh, that was fucking implicit. You tell anyone about this, I blow your fucking head off. Both your body’s and your soul’s, just for safe measure”.

Izuku chuckled softly at this, not breaking the hug.

“Fine, suit yourself, then”.

A pause.

“I’ll hug you back if you call me by my first name”.

“*Kachaaaan*”.

“Nope, that ain’t it”.

“Stop it”.

“You really can’t fucking do it?”

“Stop mocking me about it!”

“Only when I die”.

“Ughhh”.

“Fuck, I can’t believe the reason you’ve been calling me Kacchan all those years was because you didn’t know how to actually pronounce my name”.

“That wasn’t the only reason!”

“Sure wasn’t”.

“It was not!”

“Yeah, right”.

“What, are you saying you’d rather have me calling you *Bakugou*?”

Katsuki tensed up, his stomach twisting. He could feel Izuku tense up as well.

A pregnant, awkward pause.

“That was so weird”.

“Tell me the fuck about it”.

“Let’s agree to never do it again?”

“Whatever”.

“Ok”.

Another pause. Longer this time.

“So for how much longer do you plan to keep clinging to me like a fucking koala?”

Izuku’s arms went slacker around Katsuki’s torso, but he didn’t let go entirely.

“Do you want me to let go?”

“I think this is just getting too fucking weird now”.

“But did it help?”

“With what?”

“I… don’t know. With whatever it was that was making you so nervous”.

“I wasn’t fucking nervous”.

“Fine. Frantic, then”.

“Wasn’t frantic either”.

“*Kacchan*”.

“I don’t know, Deku”, he sighed, tired, but also weirdly calmer than before. The confusion was still there, but it was somewhat dormant, now. “I just know I want you to let go, now”.

Izuku broke the hug and took a step back, studying Katsuki’s face with close attention as if he was trying his best to notice the effects of his hug.

“You’re feeling better”.

Katsuki rolled his eyes and walked past him with indifference.

“You think you’re so damn smart, don’t you, shitty nerd”.

“I *am* smart”, Izuku pointed out. “And I can also feel what you feel. So I know you’re feeling better”.

“Do you want a fucking trophy or something?”

“No”, Izuku immediately responded, as if the idea offended him. “I didn’t do it for a reward”.

Katsuki threw himself on his bed, using one of his arms as a pillow, and rolled his eyes extra hard just so Deku could see it. This was one of the things that annoyed him the most about the boy: he couldn’t say one single thing without meaning it that Deku thought he was serious. This was precisely the reason why Deku often got so hurt by Katsuki’s words (not that Katsuki denied that he had been an asshole to Deku many times; but sometimes, the times when he wasn’t trying to be an asshole, were the times that Deku got the most upset).

“I fucking now that, dipshit”, he said.

“O-Oh”, Izuku blinked blankly at him, not knowing how to respond. Before Katsuki could say anything else, his phone vibrated in his pocket, and he retrieved it to find a new text from Kirishima.

From: Shitty Hair

Mina told me you guys went to the mall today

From: Shitty Hair

Did you guys forget all about me? :c

From: Bakubro

Cut this shit out

From: Shitty Hair

Wow babe

From: Shitty Hair

Bro**

From: Shitty Hair

It was the autocorrect

From: Shitty Hair

So what have you been up to?

"Aren't you going to study?", Izuku asked, sounding like he was trying to push past his hesitation and sound more confident towards Bakugou, now that they had hugged.

"Nah", Katsuki said as he typed on his phone. He had to find a way to diverge from that subject, lest Kirishima get suspicious they were making plans for his birthday next week. "We have class early tomorrow and the shitshow from today left me fucking tired", he added absentmindedly.

From: Bakubro

I was thinking

From: Bakubro

And maybe, for the first time in your shitty life, you may have been right

From: Shitty Hair

Thanks…?

From: Shitty Hair

About what tho?

From: Shitty Hair

Also, I'm still waiting on a reply to why you guys didn't invite me to the mall

From: Shitty Hair

Did I do smth? :'(

From: Bakubro

Shut up

From: Bakubro

You were right about the feelings shit

From: Bakubro

Maybe I'm only feeling things because Deku feels them

From: Bakubro

That would explain why I used to hate him and now I feel the f-word for him

"Oh, ok", Izuku said, trying to act cool. "I think I'll sleep too, then. I'm also kind of tired".

"Hm", was Katsuki's simple grunt.

From: Shitty Hair

You feel the WHAT

Incoming call from: Shitty Hair

Declined

From: Bakubro

The fuck are you calling me for

Incoming call from: Shitty Hair

Declined

From: Bakubro

STOP CALLING ME.

Incoming call from: Shitty Hair

Declined

Incoming call from: Shitty Hair

Declined

Incoming call from: Shitty Hair

Declined

From: Shitty Hair

BAKUGOU WHAT THE HELL DO YOU MEAN

From: Shitty Hair

PICK UP

Incoming call from: Shitty Hair

Declined

From: Bakubro

STOP FUCKING CALLING ME

"Uh, Kacchan", Izuku frowned at him, having climbed to his side of the bed. He was lying down beside Katsuki, from the other side of the pillow fort that was a constant on Katsuki's bed now. "Are you ok?"

"Yeah", Katsuki said simply, trying not to break his phone screen with his thumbs from the way he was tapping on it so hard as he wrote a message to Kirishima. "If you wanna sleep, then just do it", he added.

Izuku hesitated, sounding like he wanted to say something, but couldn't find the courage to. Funny how he'd been brave enough to hug Katsuki just a few minutes before, but now it was like all the determination had been sucked out of him.

From: Bakubro

JUST TYPE DOWN WHATEVER IT IS YOU WANT TO SAY YOU FUCKING ANIMAL

From: Shitty Hair

WHAT THE HELL IS THE F-WORD

From: Shitty Hair

WHAT DO YOU FEEL FOR MIDORIYA

From: Bakubro

IT'S FONDNESS YOU STUPID IDIOT

From: Shitty Hair

JESUS CHRIST ARE YOU TRYING TO GIVE ME A HEART ATTACK

From: Bakubro

STOP FUCKING SCREAMING AT ME

From: Shitty Hair

YOU'RE THE ONE WHO STARTED SCREAMING

From: Bakubro

WHAT THE FUCK DID YOU EVEN THINK I MEANT BY F-WORD??

From: Shitty Hair

BAKUGOU ARE YOU SERIOUSLY ASKING ME THAT QUESTION OH MY GOD

From: Shitty Hair

WHAT DO YOU THINK I THOUGHT YOU MEANT BY “F-WORD” BAKUGOU?????

From: Bakubro

I DON’T FUCKING KNOW THAT’S WHY I’M ASKING

From: Bakubro

I DON’T KNOW WHY YOU’RE SO FUCKING RILED UP I JUST TOLD YOU SOMETHING YOU ALREADY KNEW ABOUT THE FEELINGS

From: Bakubro

WE HAD THAT CONVERSATION YESTERDAY

From: Shitty Hair

How is it possible that you’re so fucking innocent while being a vicious explodo king at the same time

From: Bakubro

The fuck did you just say??????

From: Bakubro

I ain’t fucking innocent

From: Bakubro

Also you’re clearly out of your damn mind so just talk to me when you’ve regained your fucking senses

From: Bakubro

Dipshit

From: Shitty Hair

NO WAIT

From: Bakubro

Bye

From: Shitty Hair

NO

Katsuki turned his phone off and shoved it beneath his pillow, angry. Why the fuck had Kirishima reacted like that? And why did he always have to overreact so fucking much? It pissed Katsuki off.

Only after he nestled himself against his pillows and relaxed, closing his eyes in an attempt to forget all about Kirishima's lack of fucking sense and go to sleep, was that he remembered that he had meant to ask Deku something, after they were done with the ridiculous hug and before his thought process was interrupted by Kirishima's text. Peeking over the pillow fort separating them, Katsuki tried to find out whether Deku was still awake or already sleeping, but it was impossible to tell since his green curls were hiding his face away from view.

"Hey, dumbass", Katsuki called, just in case Deku was still awake. "You gonna tell me why you were so sad yesterday or what?"

He waited in silent expectation for several moments, but received no response. As he settled himself on his side of the bed once more, Katsuki found that he still had no clue whether Deku was already asleep or not.

Chapter End Notes

This one was a handful and it cost me a lot of sweat and tears to finish, but I hope it's worth the wait! I'm not really happy with it and it's definitely not my favorite chapter so far, but we're getting there.
Poor Bakugou is just so bad at emotions that he'd rather run away from them entirely. Someone help him for god's sake
As always thanks for commenting and please do give me your feedback! Do be nice please because it's 2am and I have to wake up in 3 hours but I just REALLY love writing this story so it's worth every single second
Kudos are appreciated as well ❤

Chapter 12: Kirishima's Birthday Party

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Kacchan”.

“Hmm”.

“Psst. Kacchan. Are you awake?”

“Hmpf”.

“Hey. I can’t tell if you’re awake or not just by grunting. You’re *always* grunting”.

Katsuki shifted, covering his face with a pillow.

“Really?”

“Shuddup”, he groaned, voice sleepy and hoarse.

A sigh.

“Fine. I’ll wait until you’re awake”.

“Hmm”.

“Why don’t you ever listen, huh?”

“Everything’s as clear as day, but you still don’t see it”.

“I don’t know what I have to do for you to see”.

“K-K-Kacchan”.

He was covered in red.

“Deku”, a horrified whisper as his eyes grew wide.

“K-Kacchan…”

He falls to his knees, which immediately become damp from the pool of blood covering the floor.

“T-This… T-This is…”, a wet cough, a wheeze, a pained gasp. Katsuki doesn’t know what to do with his hands, so they hover, shaky, above Deku’s broken, bleeding body. He’s aware that his eyes are painfully wide, and he is, for the first time ever, at a loss for words, but Deku’s hand is clutching the front of his battered hero uniform and pulling him closer so that Katsuki can hear his low, hoarse voice better. He doesn’t bat Deku’s hands away, holding them in his instead.

“You – stay down”, he says, and he sounds so hesitant, so vulnerable, so weak. He hates himself for it. He places a hand against Deku’s shoulder and pushes him back down, because what if his spine is damaged, what if moving aggravates his wounds, he needs to stay down, he needs to stay still –

“K-Kacchan…”, Deku attempts again, not listening to him as usual. There’s blood tinging his teeth pink, and it’s disgusting, and Katsuki hates it. The whistling, wheezing sound that Deku’s breathing emits makes him nauseous. Katsuki doesn’t have any idea what to do. He’s not the best with rescues, he’s not the best with this. He sucks at comforting people. Deep down, he knows Deku is dying, so he does what he does best. He masks his fear and panic with rage.

“Shut the fuck up and do as I say for once in your fucking life, you little piece of shit”, he bites, angry, squeezing Deku’s hands more tightly than necessary. The words don’t come out in the form of a scream, as they would usually, but as a threat murmured through gritted teeth. His eyes are still wide, he knows, but he tries to make them angry, he tries to make them free of the fear that’s making his heart race in his chest.

Because Deku is dying. He’s dying and there’s nothing he can do. Deku coughs again, tiny droplets of blood contacting with Katsuki’s pale, unharmed face. He tries to hate him for that, but fails. Because Deku is dying. Deku took the blow for him and now he’s dying in his place. It should have been him. It *would* have been him, if Deku hadn’t –

“T-This is y-your fault. And… y-you’re not even sorry, a-are you?” Deku says, a flash of hurt appearing in his eyes for a split-second right before his hands go slack in Katsuki’s grasp and his chest goes still. His body relaxes and droops against the floor, his head lolling slightly to the side now that Deku could no longer keep his neck strained up. There’s still blood bubbling out the corner of his parted lips and rolling down his freckled cheek with a sickening slowness, but he no longer has a pulse, and his eyes are open and unseeing, fixed on Katsuki with an empty expression. The hurt is gone from them.

The sight made Katsuki remember something very frightening, but before he could tell what it was, Deku’s body dissipated beneath his hands, disappearing from view as if it had never been there in the first place. Katsuki toppled to the side at the sudden absence, shocked, his eyes still wide as saucers, desperately searching for Deku but unable to find him anywhere.

He woke with a jolt, eyes wide.

He couldn’t breathe, air stuck in his lungs after a loud gasp, until he looked over the pile of pillows, finding Deku to be asleep on the other side. His back was turned to Katsuki and he was lying on his side in a fetal position, as usual. His breathing was even, not ragged, or wheezing, or shallow as it had been in Katsuki’s nightmare just a moment before. Katsuki couldn’t see Deku’s face from that angle, but he looked asleep. He sounded asleep. There was no blood covering him, no wound maiming him. He looked completely, undeniably *fine*, and yet Katsuki’s heart was still racing, and he was still holding his breath without realizing it.

He let the air inside him escape in the form of a shaky sigh, toppling back against his pillow and staring up at the ceiling with a frown. The fight or flight instinct that had jolted him into awakening dissipated from inside him and he relaxed, pursing his lips into a thin, displeased line.

It had just been a dream. Nothing more. There was no reason for him to freak out so damn hard.

And yet…

He shifted on the bed so that his back was turned to Deku, pulling the covers up to his chin and glaring at his wardrobe. Stupid fucking Deku, can’t leave him the hell alone even in his dreams.

Katsuki grabbed his phone with an annoyed sigh in order to check what time it was and if he was anywhere close to getting up for class, but then he remembered he had turned it off in

order to ignore Kirishima right before going to sleep. Turning it back on (and continuing to ignore the wave of text messages that flooded his inbox as soon as he did), he found that it was still 2 a.m., which meant he wouldn't have to get up for another three hours. A shiver ran through his body when a cold breeze invaded the room through the tiny space between his closed curtains, so Katsuki tucked himself more comfortably inside his covers and nestled on his pillows.

He closed his eyes, trying his best to rid his mind of memories of blood and ragged breaths and hands grabbing him. It hadn't been real, none of that. It had just been a stupid dream, a stupid scenario his mind had come up with for no reason. There was no reason for him to dwell on that, and there was definitely no reason for him to *panic* over that. All he had to do was to fall sleep again, and when he woke up, he wouldn't even remember about the fucking nightmare in the first place.

He shivered again.

Fuck.

Why was it so fucking cold anyway? He threw his covers away with annoyance, standing up from the bed and approaching the window. It was barely even open, but Katsuki still pushed it closed all the way with a loud bang.

There. Now no stupid night breeze would find its way inside his bedroom. He threw himself on the bed again, not caring if the mattress rattled from his weight, before pulling his covers back on and nestling against his pillows once more.

He sighed, closing his eyes. Now all he needed to do was empty his mind and concentrate on sleeping again. He needed to be well-rested for class. He couldn't risk falling behind *again*. Not because of stupid Deku *again*. He just had to sleep. It was pretty fucking simple.

But no matter how hard he fucking tried, Katsuki simply couldn't find sleep anymore. Even though his window was closed and there was no more breeze in the room, his body was still cold, shivering and trembling as he shrunk harder onto himself in an attempt to preserve warmth. God fucking *damn* it, why was he shivering so hard?

He pulled yet another cover on top of himself, he got up again and put a warmer shirt on, he even put fucking socks on (which was something he never did). And yet, no matter how hard he tried, he was still shivering as if Icy Hot had decided to rile him up by turning his room into a freezing chamber.

It was only then a realization dawned upon Katsuki.

He tilted his head in order to glance at Deku again. The boy was still lying in the same fetal position, doubled over himself. Watching him for a few long moments, Katsuki could finally notice that he was shivering, even though the motion was barely perceptible in the darkness of the room.

Fucking *great*.

Was that it? Really, was that *fucking* it?

With a tired sigh – he really wanted to forget about the nightmare and just go the fuck to *sleep* –, Katsuki took one of his covers and threw it on the top of Deku, hoping to warm him up. However, much to his surprise – which shouldn't have been the case, since this was a rather obvious conclusion –, the cover phased straight through Deku, flopping down on the top of the bed beneath the boy's soul.

Great. The covers couldn't fucking touch Deku. How goddamn fucking *wonderful*.

Katsuki scowled, well aware that there was only one way he would be able to warm Deku up, and in consequence, himself.

He sighed, shoving his head on his pillows again. He didn't want to do this. He *really* didn't want to do this.

Being hugged by Inko had already been a handful. Being hugged by *Deku* was a whole new level of weirdness, even if Katsuki couldn't deny that the experience hadn't been as loathsome as he had expected it to be. But this – the solution his brain had come up with, which Katsuki knew very well was the only possible solution in that situation – this was *way* too much.

What was he even doing? Was he actually considering *cuddling* with Deku in order to warm him up? Was that how fucking far he had fallen? Was that how weak he had become?

What a stupid fucking idea. Katsuki turned his back to Deku again and squeezed his eyes shut, threatening himself into falling asleep. As if he would ever allow himself to fucking cuddle with fucking Deku, of all people. As fucking *if*.

He shivered again, and pulled the covers closer to himself. It was useless.

He tried to count sheep, until he became too bored and started thinking about blowing them up. Then, he started to count how many explosions it took to scare the imaginary sheep away, then he started to count grenades instead of sheep, then he grew bored again. He knew what would happen if he allowed boredom to overtake his brain. His mind would wander to places Katsuki didn't want it to tread in, and he couldn't afford that.

Blood, and coughs, and *this is your fault* whispered by a dying Deku. What the fuck had he meant by that, anyway? How could the nerd's death be Katsuki's fault in any way?

Stupid asshole. Katsuki knew that this had only been a dream and nothing more, because the *real* Deku would never waste his dying breaths to say something like that. He would never want Katsuki to live the rest of his life feeling guilty for his death, *especially* if it had actually been Katsuki's fault.

Katsuki found himself surprised by that realization. It was true, wasn't it? Katsuki could personally pull the trigger that resulted on Deku's death, and Deku would still never accuse him of it.

He tried to convince himself that he only thought that because Deku liked to be a martyr, so he would never fucking shove that responsibility onto Katsuki and, in consequence, deprive himself from the glory of giving his life for someone else's. But, deep down, Katsuki knew the real reason why Deku wouldn't throw such an accusation to his face in his dying moments, especially if he really was to blame.

For some twisted, messed up reason Katsuki couldn't understand for the life of him, Deku cared about him. Even though he hated to admit it, Deku had *always* cared about him, no matter how hard Katsuki had always tried to make him stop caring. The truth was: he wouldn't say something like that to Katsuki. He was too much of a wimp to do so. He was too much of a coward to even hate Katsuki for all the messed-up stuff he did to the nerd throughout their childhoods. And, even though Katsuki struggled to understand Deku's reasons, Deku didn't want to see Katsuki hurt. He just knew that. Because Deku had made that pretty fucking clear.

Deku had taken the fucking blow for him, in *real life*. Which was why they were in this fucked up situation.

And what pissed him off the most about all this was that he knew *Deku* knew that there was nothing that would hurt Katsuki more than being to blame for Deku's death.

Because no matter how much Katsuki had hated Deku in the past; no matter how much Katsuki wanted to be better than him and make him eat his dust, Katsuki had never actually wanted him to *die*. Which was why the whole "throw yourself off the rooftop" shit still pissed him off to this day – he didn't actually fucking mean it. How could Deku not realize that? Katsuki didn't want him to fucking die. He just wanted him to get the fuck out of his way with his superiority and his self-righteousness, as if a quirkless fucking loser could get into the same school as him, could be a better hero than him…

But Deku had made it, hadn't he? Despite being a *quirkless loser*, he still caught All Might's attention. All Might's admiration. All Might's fucking *quirk*.

Whereas Katsuki, with all his hard training, with all his praise, with all his unfaltering certainty that he was bound to be number one… Katsuki was below *shitty Deku*. He had fucking fallen behind someone who was so much weaker than him.

Which only proved *he* was the weak one.

And it didn't matter that Deku had a quirk or not. Even back when he had been a quirkless loser… He had already been better than Katsuki. Because All fucking Might wouldn't have chosen him as a successor otherwise, would he? And maybe, just maybe… Deku's constant meddling wasn't a sign of him thinking he was superior to Katsuki. Maybe it was a sign of his heroism. Of his altruism. Of his fucking righteous will to become a hero, just to save people. Not for the fame, or the praise, or the money… But only to *do good*.

Like willingly taking a deadly blow in the place of the guy who bullied him throughout his entire life.

Shit.

If that was truly the case, then… Katsuki not only had a lot to rethink about his ideas of what a hero was, but also a lot to improve about himself.

And it pissed him off to no end, to think that shitty Deku had already been better than him for so long. It pissed him off that Deku's motivations were nobler, that Deku's improvement was quicker, that Deku's shitty self was more praiseworthy. And this all made it easier for Katsuki to convince himself that this was just an act, that this was just Deku fooling everyone into thinking he was the nicest fucking guy when he was actually the worst, but after everything he'd seen and everything they'd lived together, especially in these past weeks, Katsuki *knew* that wasn't true. He hated that he fucking knew it, but he did.

And he also knew that he couldn't keep trying to blame Deku for his own problems and insecurities. He couldn't keep projecting his frustration regarding his own weakness, his anger, his jealousy, his fucking *emotions* on shitty Deku just because his head was too far up in his ass for him to deal with all that shit. They were way past that. *He* was way past that. And as long as he kept using shitty Deku as an outlet for his own flaws, instead of owning them… The damn nerd would keep surpassing him. He would still be at the top.

Katsuki needed to figure his shit out for once. Because the more energy he spent on belittling fucking Deku, who had, obviously, managed to surpass him *despite* all the years of belittlement, the less energy he could focus on improving his fucking self. Which, honestly, should be his top priority at the moment, because he was falling behind. And it didn't matter that he could recognize Deku's merit and admit that maybe he wasn't the petulant asshole he had always assumed the nerd to be – Katsuki still wanted to be better than him.

This is your fault. And you're not even sorry, are you?

Are you?

Are *you?*

Fuck, of course he was. Of *course* he fucking was. He didn't want shitty Deku to die, and he especially didn't want him to die in his place. He didn't want to be weak. He didn't want to be fucking rescued as if he was a helpless princess in need of a savior. He could damn well fend for himself, or die trying. Why couldn't shitty Deku respect that? Why couldn't he worry about his own damn ass for a change? Why couldn't he just take care of his damn self and stop diving headfirst into danger whenever it appeared in front of him?

He had always been like that, even as a kid, even before they had quirks. Always shoving his nose where it wasn't meant to be, always meddling with other people's businesses with that fucking concerned look in his eyes, always trying to save people even though *he* was the only helpless one. Thinking about it, Deku was really fucking lucky to have gotten so far into his fucking life, given how reckless he was.

How reckless he'd been.

Fuck. Katsuki couldn't stop thinking about the blood. There had been so much of it… pooling beneath Deku, seeping into his trousers as he kneeled beside his body, running down his pale cheek… And the bastard had the gut to blame him for it. He had the gut to accuse

Katsuki, to make him guilty, to fucking – tell him the fucking words – he dreaded. He knew it had only been a dream, but it still pissed him off that Deku would even think about doing that – about throwing such an accusation at Katsuki right before kicking the fucking bucket, leaving him to deal with that sort of guilt and blame for the rest of his life while he was safe in his damn grave.

He didn't want Deku to die. He didn't want Deku to die for *him*.

Katsuki couldn't *stop thinking about it,* no matter how imaginary the fucking scenario had been. He tried to convince himself that being so shaken by something so ridiculous and completely unreal was pathetic. *He* was being pathetic. He was being weak, and if he was weak, Deku would continue to stomp him down until he was a forgotten name in a footnote of Deku's biography. And he would be *damned* if he let that happen.

He would stop thinking about the fucking nightmare. He would stop thinking about the blood and Deku's accusation and the things that he felt as he watched Deku die. He would stop trying to figure out what that meant, and he would instead focus on his own self, on his own improvement, on his own wishes.

It wasn't like seeing Deku's dead eyes staring at nothing yet again had bothered him. It wasn't like he was currently losing sleep over an imaginary fucking scenario his shitty brain had come up with just to torment him, and it wasn't like he was fucking tormented, and fucking great, now he couldn't stop thinking about it. And shivering, for that matter.

It was so fucking cold.

Why had the fucking nightmare even stuck with him anyway? Katsuki had never been bothered by this sort of shit before. He could tell dream from reality, thank you very much, and thinking about Deku dying shouldn't be something that caused him such distraught. He should be in fucking control of his feelings. He should be ignoring this shit and getting some sleep.

He shivered again.

Fuck it. God fucking damn it, he *hated* this.

"Oi. Deku".

No answer. Katsuki's arm went past the barrier provided by the pillow fort and he poked Deku's arm with more force than necessary.

"Deku. Wake the fuck up".

It still took Izuku a few moments of sleepy confusion to startle into awareness and tilt his head to stare at Katsuki with glazed eyes and a messy hair. Fuck, the green curls were falling all over his freckled face, making him look ridiculous. Katsuki gritted his teeth.

"Kacchan…?", Izuku asked, voice slurred by sleep. He seemed to be more asleep than awake, his eyes squinting at Katsuki's face in blurry recognition and looking like they were

about to droop closed any second. “Wha’ happened? Something happened? Wha’?”

“Shut up”, Katsuki said aggressively. Izuku frowned.

“Huh?”

“I said shut up. Are you cold?”

“Huh?”

“Just answer the fucking question”.

“I – ‘m what?”

“Are you fucking cold or not?”

Izuku continued to frown at him, looking lost and confused.

“’M sleepy”.

Then he turned back on his side and closed his eyes, going back to sleep.

“Don’t ignore me, you fucking bastard”, Katsuki poked him again, hard. “You’re fucking shivering”.

Izuku blinked his eyes open again blankly, as if only then realizing the truth behind Katsuki’s words.

“Y-Yeah, tha’ too. But why?”

“Because you’re a fucking wimp, so it’s not surprising to anyone that you’re fucking cold”.

Izuku frowned, turning his sleepy head to look at Katsuki from beneath half-open lids.

“…Whatcha doing?”

“What the fuck does it look like I’m doing?”

“I’m – I don’t…?“

“Stop making such a fuss about this. I don’t wanna feel cold, you don’t wanna feel cold, so that’s all there is to this”.

“*You’re* feelin’ cold?”

“The fuck do you think, asshole? I can feel what you feel, so take a guess”.

Izuku blinked at him, looking slightly more sober but still pretty much out of it.

“Kacchan, you don’ have–“

“Just shut up and stop making this weird”.

Throwing the last pillow down on the floor, Katsuki dragged himself to the center of the bed, now that he had dismantled the pillow fort. Izuku continued to stare at him, looking like he was trying to figure out whether he was still asleep and this was a dream, or if he was awake and this was actually happening. He only moved when Katsuki outstretched an arm to the side and gave him an impatient eyebrow raise.

Izuku swallowed dry and dragged himself closer to Kacchan on the bed. He was hesitant, but also too sleepy to put much thought into his actions. Kacchan didn’t move – he simply lied still, one of his arms outstretched in order to support Izuku, waiting for the boy to nestle against him and use him as a human furnace.

Izuku was very silent as he rested his head on the spot between Kacchan’s shoulder and his chest, face purposefully blank and eyes blinking stupidly. Katsuki could feel just how tense he was as he closed his arm around Izuku’s torso, holding him in place. He, himself, was also tense.

Neither of them spoke. All they could hear was each other’s breathing in the otherwise silent room.

This felt like a huge leap. Until the day before, Katsuki could barely stand touching Izuku – or anyone, for that matter. Then, Inko had hugged him, and Deku had hugged him… And now they were cuddling. It did feel good, and the deep, shivering cold he had been feeling moments before was slowly dissipating, but at the same time, it felt *wrong*. Wrong, and *way* too fast.

He shouldn’t be this close to anyone – especially not to Deku. That had been the whole point of the pillow fort. And yes, Katsuki was only doing this because Deku was cold, not because he wanted Deku to be physically close to him or anything. He was only doing this to keep Deku warm, so that he could fall asleep and get some proper fucking rest.

It wasn’t like now that Katsuki knew what physical affection felt like, he longed for more. Nope. Nothing like that. He was just trying to warm Deku up so that he could be warm too and that was all there was to it.

He could feel the pattern of Deku’s breathing against his body. In, out. In, out. In out. If he concentrated really hard, he could also feel Deku’s pulse thumping against his skin. Rhythmical. Steady. Present.

There.

Deku was breathing, his heart was beating. He was ok.

Also, he was no longer fucking cold, which was definitely a win.

Katsuki sighed and closed his eyes. Thinking about a dead Deku was a bit harder when there were constant, close reminders that he was alive and right there, glued against Katsuki’s skin.

“Thanks, Kaccha’”, Deku whispered quietly after a while, sounding like he was asleep again. His voice was muffled by Katsuki’s chest. Deku had relaxed against him, his curly hair making Katsuki’s chin and neck tingle.

As he spoke, Katsuki could feel his warm breath contacting with the skin of his chest, and wondered if it was possible to feel repulse and longing for the same person at the same time. He wanted to shove Deku away, because all this touching was too much, it was fucking *overwhelming*, at the same time he wanted to pull Deku closer and hold him tight if only he would be able to tell he was alive. Feeling Deku’s skin against his was overwhelming; it wasn’t something Katsuki was used to having. With *anyone*. He didn’t do hugs, or cuddles. He didn’t know how.

He didn’t think he had ever touched a person for so long in his life, and he had no idea how to feel about that. Especially since that person was Deku, the guy who he put down his whole life, the guy who he thought he hated, the guy who was his rival.

The guy who had willingly put his life on the line to save his lame ass.

It was like Katsuki was only realizing that for the first time. Yeah, he had recovered his memories from the incident, and yeah, he had heard from several people – and from Deku himself – about what had happened. And, even though there had been no blood and no gruesome wounds coloring Deku’s body back when the villain separated him from his soul… Katsuki couldn’t get the image off his mind. And he couldn’t stop thinking about how shitty Deku hadn’t thought twice about taking the damn blow for him, despite all their falling outs, despite everything that set them apart.

Fine, maybe Katsuki owed Deku just a little bit. Just for saving his life again. Not that he would ever admit that out loud, though.

So he simply lay there, stiff as a stone, staring up at his ceiling and not moving an inch. Deku was back to sleep against him in the matter of seconds, snoring softly against his chest. He was probably tired, after all the emotional turmoil from the previous day. Katsuki was fucking tired too.

The feeling of coldness disappeared from his hands and feet as Deku unconsciously snuggled closer to him in his sleep, emitting a tiny grunt as he moved and clung to the front of Katsuki’s shirt.

Fuck. This was pathetic. What was he *doing*?

He may not hate Deku anymore, but that didn’t mean he liked him, right? Feeling the f-word for him didn’t mean he liked him, it just meant… It just meant that he didn’t want Deku to *die* or some shit. That was what fondness meant, right? Not wanting someone to die a gruesome death? He made himself a mental reminder to double check that conclusion with Kirishima later, but then he remembered how annoying and confusing his friend had been when he talked about the f-word earlier, and decided against it.

Whatever he felt for Deku now – this non-hate and non-liking – was his problem, and his alone. He would have to deal with it alone. It wasn’t like he needed anyone’s help to figure

his own feelings out; they were *his* fucking feelings.

Katsuki closed his eyes and went back to counting grenades, telling himself that he absolutely needed to fucking sleep at once and stop thinking about shitty Deku and emotions and Kirishima's crappy ideas. For some reason he couldn't put his finger on, sleeping didn't seem so unattainable now that he didn't feel so cold anymore. And as his brain sunk into unconsciousness and his body finally relaxed beneath Deku's, Katsuki fell into a dreamless sleep that, at the very least, wasn't plagued with any more nightmares.

If Deku being close to Katsuki to the point of him being able to feel the pattern of his breathing had any interference on that matter, Katsuki didn't know, and probably wouldn't be able to tell anyway.

When Katsuki woke up in the morning, they were still cuddling.

Deku's hand was lax on the top of his chest, his head still nestled between Katsuki's neck and his shoulder. One of his legs had been thrown, shamelessly, above Katsuki's hip while he slept, making him look like he was clinging to Katsuki like a koala or some shit. Katsuki couldn't quite see the nerd's face from the amount of green curls shielding it away from view. If the pattern of Deku's breathing was anything to go by, he was still fast asleep.

Katsuki felt his face burn and pursed his lips into a thin, stern line. *Fuck*. What the hell was he doing? Why the hell did he allow himself to get into this situation in the first place? And how the fuck would he even look Deku in the eye when he woke up?

This whole shit had seemed like a great fucking idea back in the middle of the night, like all ideas do. But now that the morning had come, and now that Katsuki had gotten some rest and could finally think straight, he could realize how fucking ridiculous this was. How fucking ridiculous this *had been*.

Cuddling with Deku? What the fuck was he even doing? Deku should have been the last person in the world Katsuki would have agreed to cuddle with. He should have preferred to freeze over even getting anywhere near the nerd. Why the fuck had he allowed himself to do that? Why the fuck had he become so weak?

He didn't want to think about it. Until the day before, Katsuki couldn't *stand* the thought of being hugged, and now shitty Deku was clinging to him as if there was no fucking tomorrow. And he was *letting* him. Fuck, no, he had *invited* shitty Deku in the first place.

He would have never thought that being hugged by Inko would have turned out to be an important enough of event to trigger such a sudden change of behavior in his head. Was he really *that* touch starved that being hugged by shitty Deku and his mom, with actual care, with actual love, had caused him to long for… more?

Fuck, no. Hell, no. He didn't want to deal with *that*.

He remembered the first – and only other – time he had cuddled with Deku, a week before. He had forgotten to put the pillow fort up before going to sleep, and Deku had clung to him like a koala, exactly like he was doing on that moment. And Katsuki had felt so fucking embarrassed by that that he hadn't even wanted Deku to know what had happened. He had removed Deku from the top of him carefully, mindful not to wake him up…

Now, he just wanted to get away. Hell, he *needed* to get away. All this fucking physical contact at once was way too much for his touch-starved ass.

He shoved Izuku away from him abruptly, without caring if he would wake the boy up with the rough movement. He stood up from the bed, heading to the bathroom.

Before he entered, he spared the boy on the bed a quick, simple glimpse. Deku had turned on his side, still asleep, trying – and failing – to cuddle with a nearby pillow at Katsuki's absence. As his arm phased through the warm pillow, Deku sighed in discontent and, still unconscious, turned on his other side, going back to his usual fetal position.

Katsuki glared at him for several moments that felt like an eternity, not knowing what to do with himself – or what to think, for that matter.

Then he walked into the bathroom, deciding he was better off not dwelling over it.

They didn't hug anymore.

Probably because Katsuki never asked for it again, and Izuku didn't know how to offer it without making it sound weird or making it look like he was needy. But, at the end of the day, Izuku didn't offer it, Katsuki didn't ask for it, and they went on with their lives without hugging, or barely even touching each other unless absolutely necessary.

This went on for a while.

On the morning following the cuddling session, Katsuki went about his normal routine – he worked out, took a shower, ignored Deku when he woke up, walked leisurely to class,

ignored Deku's questions about the lectures, had lunch, went back to classes, went back to the dorm. At night, he put up the pillow fort without looking at Deku or saying anything about it, as if nothing out of the ordinary had happened in the past day and in the past night. Deku didn't complain about it. In fact, he didn't even look surprised about it, which made Katsuki wonder if he even *remembered* that they had cuddled at all. He had been so sleepy that it was well fucking possible the damn nerd had assumed everything had just been a dream.

Katsuki was ok with that, really. It was better to have Deku forget all about it then remember and try to bring it up, like the tactless ass he was.

On the following morning, the routine was repeated. Wake up. Work out. Go to class. Have lunch. Class again. Go back to the dorm. Put the pillow fort up. Fall asleep. Not touch each other.

Wake up. Work out. Go to class. Have lunch. Class again. Go back to the dorm. Put the pillow fort up. Fall asleep. Not touch each other.

Wake up. Work out. Go to class. Have lunch. Class again. Go back to the dorm. Put the pillow fort up. Fall asleep. Not touch each other.

They never spoke about it. Izuku didn't offer, Katsuki didn't ask. They still bantered at each other, and talked about other things. Katsuki still complained about shit, Izuku still asked for him to ask teachers stupid questions. But Izuku was getting better at controlling his sadness, and Katsuki was getting better at putting up with the nerd's constant shit without wanting to blow a hole up in his face. In fact, he was even starting to listen to what Deku had to say a bit more – not that he ever stopped complaining about it. Overall, they were doing good – better than they had a week before, or even at any previous point of their lives.

They were getting more used to each other. And, more than anything, they were getting to *know* each other. It was pretty fucking ironic that, after over a decade of knowing each other, they were only now getting to *really* know each other. Katsuki was only now discovering what Deku's favorite food was, what Deku's favorite school subject was, what Deku liked to talk about with his friends… He was only now discovering that Deku had the same habit as him of holding his chin while he got lost in thought, that Deku usually itched the back of his neck when he didn't understand something, that Deku waved his hands frantically in front of himself whenever he was embarrassed and trying to justify himself.

That Deku's hair smelled like rain and jasmine. That Deku's freckles occupied most of his face, and actually looked nice on him. That Deku liked to stare out the window in the morning, watching the world come to life outside. That Deku moved a fucking lot in his sleep. That Deku's favorite sleeping position was fetal. That Deku would usually stick the tip of his tongue past his closed lips whenever he was concentrating on something. That when Deku wasn't muttering to himself, he was humming songs Katsuki didn't know under his breath in distraction. That Deku liked to lie on his back on the bed with his head hanging off the mattress and watch whatever Katsuki was doing upside down. That Deku had a lot of fucking mannerisms that Katsuki had never even fucking noticed in all those years they spent right next to one another.

But they still didn’t touch. And, to anyone who didn’t know better, things looked almost… normal.

Katsuki wanted to be hugged, but he wouldn’t ask for it. Izuku wanted to hug him, but he was too afraid to make things weird by continuously offering it, or downright hugging Katsuki without an invitation. So they didn’t touch each other. And they didn’t act like they wanted to.

Izuku wanted to.

(Katsuki did, too).

They were getting better at a lot of things, but being honest about what they wanted and felt still wasn’t one of them.

Then, a few uneventful days later, Kirishima’s birthday came.

“Your trap is unusually shut today”.

“Are you saying you want me to talk more?”

“Hell fucking no. I’m just saying I get weirded out when you’re unusually quiet. It usually means you’re up to something”.

“No, it doesn’t!”

“Fine. It usually means you’re moping about something, and you don’t plan on telling me about it, which never fails to drive me fucking insane”.

A pause.

“It’s… nothing, really. I’m just… thinking, that’s all”.

“Didn’t know you could do that”.

“*Haha*”.

“If it’s something, just fucking tell me about it at once. You’re getting better at keeping your sappy feelings to yourself, and I don’t want to go back down into that fucking spiral of your mysterious misery just because you love to suffer”.

Izuku sighed in resignation, annoyed by Katsuki's insistence but acknowledging the truth behind his words. They both really had to work on being more honest with each other.

"I'm… I think I'm just worried about Kirishima-kun's birthday party, that's all".

Katsuki turned to frown at him, a confused scowl on his face.

"What the fuck? *Why*?"

Another pause. Izuku worried at his lower lip, not looking at Katsuki and staring pensively at the ceiling instead, his head hanging slightly off the edge of Katsuki's bed.

"I don't know. A lot of people will be there".

A scoff.

"Yeah, so fucking *what*? You walk around with a lot of people every damn day", he turned his head away from Deku and went back to minding his own business from where he was sitting on the floor.

"But this is different! Everyone will be interacting and there will probably be games and all my friends will be there and Kaminari-kun said something about booze and people will be having fun and –"

"Just quit the fucking rambling and go straight to the point, you damn nerd".

A sigh.

"It's just… Everybody will be interacting and having fun, but… no one will be able to see me".

Another scoff.

"The fuck are you talking about? I'll be able to see you just fine".

"*Yes*, Kacchan, but you're not really great at interacting with people –"

"*Haah*?!"

" – and I don't know how I will feel about being there but not… *participating*, you know?"

"Yeah, I know just how you'll feel. Fucking *sad and mope-y*, as usual".

"I'm being serious".

"So am I".

"It'll be like I'm watching from the backstage, and everyone will have fun, and I *want* my friends to have fun, but I also wish I could… *be* part of the fun, you know?"

“No, I fucking don’t. You think your friends don’t have fucking fun when you’re not around?”

Hesitation.

“W-What?”

“What, you think your presence is fucking primordial for them to enjoy themselves? They gotta be all mope-y and sad all the time just because you’re a fucking ghost? You think way too much of yourself, nerd”.

“I don’t think that! Of course not!”

“Doesn’t sound like it”.

“Stop teasing me, Kacchan. You know that’s not what I meant. I *want* my friends to have fun, I just want to… to…”

“To *what*?”

A sigh.

“I just want to have fun too, you know?”

Katsuki turned to glare at him.

“You saying you won’t be able to have fun ‘cause you’re stuck with me?”

“No! That’s not it!”, he waved his hands.

“I think that’s *it*”.

“It’s not, Kacchan! I only mean –“

“Yeah, I know what the *fuck* you mean. And I’ll let you fucking know that I’m fucking *great* at having fun. You’re better off stuck with me than with those bastards you call your friends”.

“Don’t call them that!”

“What, *friends*?”

“Bastards!”

An evil smirk.

“You know that’s a curse word, right, Deku? Another one straight to your book of rotten-mouthiness”.

“Stop *doing* that! I didn’t mean to curse and you know it!”

“That’s not what your mother will think when I tell her”.

“*Kacchaaaaan*!”

“But as I was saying, I’m way better at having fun than that four-eyed bastard, or Round Face, and I’m definitely better at it than *Todoroki-kun*”, he said the name in a mock voice, trying to imitate the way Deku said it while putting as much scorn and contempt in his tone as he possibly could. Izuku frowned, tilting his head.

“Why do you hate Todoroki-kun so much?”

Katsuki’s face was immediately overcome by an angry snarl.

“Why do you still use ‘kun’ to refer to him if you’re all buddy-buddy with each other?”, he asked deflectively.

Izuku blushed and looked away, which only served to make Katsuki’s snarl angrier.

“You’re changing the subject”.

“No, I’m fucking not. The Half’n’Half bastard is part of the subject, since he sucks at having fun and I excel at it”.

“Oh, really? How do you have fun, Kacchan?”

“Arm wrestles”, he responded without missing a beat.

Izuku chuckled loudly, throwing his head back and making his curls bounce with the movement. Noticing Katsuki was staring at him with seriousness written all over his face, he frowned, even though there was still humor painting his lips.

“Wait. Are you serious?”

“Of course I’m serious, you damn fucking nerd!”, Katsuki yelled.

“Ok, but that can’t be just it. What else is there on your fun list?”, Izuku encouraged with a curious expression.

“Flexing contests”.

“Oh my *god*”.

“Push up contests!”

“Kacchan, *really*?”

“Seeing who’s able to take the most punches in a row!”

“That doesn’t sound healthy at all”.

“It’s not supposed to be healthy; it’s supposed to be *fun*!”

“And I suppose you do all that with Kirishima-kun?”

“He’s the only one who’s up for it”.

“*I wonder why’s that*”.

“The fuck did you say?”

“Nothing!”

“You mocking me under your breath, nerd?”

Izuku rolled his eyes, but there was an affectionate smile on his lips.

“*No*, Kacchan. Stop trying to pick up a fight”.

“Oh, you fucking *wish* I was picking up a fight with you!”

Katsuki turned away from Izuku once again and went on about his business, which consisted of fixing something inside his suit’s gauntlet. He was sitting on the floor, the grenade-shaped gauntlet resting between his spread legs, while Izuku watched with attention from where he was lying on his belly on the bed.

“How is it going?”

“What?”

“The repairing of your gauntlet”.

“I’m not *repairing* it, shitty Deku. I’m fucking improving it”.

“How?”

“None of your business”.

A disappointed sigh.

“What, you really think I will tell you? Just so you can exploit it as a weakness whenever we go toe to toe again? As fucking *if*”.

“I would never do that and you know it, Kacchan”.

“Whatever, shitty Deku”.

Another pause. They were in blissful silence for a while, no sound in the room other than the tinkling of the screwdriver against Katsuki’s gauntlet, until –

“But really, about the party –“

“Oh my fucking *god*, you’re almost talking me out of going to this shit altogether”.

A disbelieving snort.

“As if you’d ever miss Kirishima-kun’s birthday”.

A pregnant pause. Katsuki put his screwdriver down and turned in order to stare at Deku again, whose head was right above him on the bed. He hadn’t failed to notice the subtle hurt that was etched in Deku’s voice as he spoke.

“The fuck is *that* supposed to mean?”

Izuku had the decency to look away at this, embarrassed.

“N-Nothing, I didn’t –“

“*Quit it*. Speak the fuck up”.

A resigned sigh.

“It’s just… He’s your best friend. You wouldn’t miss his birthday party just because of *me*”.

Katsuki scoffed.

“Who said it would be because of *you*? If I don’t wanna go, then I won’t go. There’s nothing anyone can do about it, especially not *you*, nerd”.

Izuku rolled his eyes.

“Do you *want* to go?”

“Yeah, I fucking do, but if you keep making demands as if I’m supposed to interact with everyone just because you’re desperate for attention, then I’ll stop *wanting* to go”.

“I’m not desperate for attention, Kacchan. I’m a *ghost*”.

“Yeah, *and*?”

“*And* it makes me upset that no one other than you can see me, or hear me, or talk to me. Is that really so hard to understand?”

Katsuki sighed and rolled his eyes. When he tilted his head up to look at Deku again, Deku had turned away from him. Given his reaction, the subject must be fucking sensitive for him, especially given the tightness that was threatening to blossom inside of Katsuki’s own chest. Fuck it.

“*Fine*. Whatever”, he turned back to his gauntlet.

“Yeah, whatever”, Izuku sighed stubbornly.

“Stop being a fucking toddler. I’ll let you interact with people”, Katsuki added over his shoulder.

“Oh, *thank you* for your permission, Kacchan”.

“Ah, shut the fuck up, nerd. You need *me* in order to talk to other people, so don’t push your fucking luck”.

“I could just scream in your ear until you decide it’s better if you just talk to them for me”.

“Yeah, you could, and I could also break all your teeth and make you swallow them one by one until your throat was too obstructed for you to keep fucking screaming”.

Izuku snorted out a laugh.

“*And* you’d feel the pain”.

“Believe me, it would be fucking worth it”.

A sigh.

“Fine, Kacchan”.

“Glad we sorted that out”.

“If you say so”.

“Quit being such a sore loser. We’ll go to the damn party and I’ll show you how people have proper fun”.

Izuku adjusted himself on the bed so that he could look at Katsuki. There was something in his eyes, something that Katsuki couldn’t quite interpret… But, whatever it was, he didn’t bring it up. Neither of them did.

“Ok”, was all Izuku said in response.

Katsuki could tell, from his eyes, that the nerd wanted to say something else, but he never did, and Katsuki never asked him about it.

That seemed to be their curse. And, in some ways, they were more similar to each other than they were willing to admit.

“Bakugou! I’m so glad you came! You’re looking fancy!”

“Ahh, Bakubro! Did you bring the cooking stuff?”

“The *what*?”

“Kaminari, stop! Pushing! It!”

“But he needs to cook! The snacks we bought won’t be enough to feed everyone!”

“What? How many did you buy?”

“Uh, a hundred…?”

“For over *twenty people*? *Baka*, I told you to buy more!”

“I didn’t have any money!”

“I *gave* you the money! And if you didn’t have money, where the hell did all that booze come from?!”

“From the money you gave me! Then I didn’t have any of it left for the sna– ahhh! No, Mina, calm down! I can explain!”

“Explain it to my fist, jackass!”

“Bakubro, save me!”

“You brought it upon yourself, douchebag”, Katsuki said with indifference as he made his way to the living room. Barely anyone had arrived yet – just Kaminari and Mina, who were in the process of wrestling each other at the entrance of the common room (Kaminari was losing); Sero, who was idly watching TV with his feet up on the couch and totally unbothered by the ongoing fight between his friends, as if that wasn’t the first time it happened that day; Sato, who was in the middle of cooking something sweet-smelling on the kitchen; and Hagakure, who Katsuki didn’t notice was there until he accidentally tripped on her invisible legs.

“Oh, sorry, Bakugou-kun! I should have moved my legs!”, she exclaimed as he barely regained his balance. He had to look for her for a moment before spotting a floating tank top and a skirt hovering above the couch. She wasn’t wearing her usual gloves, and he could barely spot her shoes amidst the carpet. No wonder why he hadn’t noticed her.

“Huh”, was all he said in acknowledgement, before making his way over to Sero and poking his head with more strength than necessary in order to call his attention. “Oi, jackass. Where am I supposed to put this? You jerks made a spot for the gifts or something?”, he waved the bag which contained the Crimson Riot plush in front of his friend, an inquiring, grumpy look on his face.

“What the hell is that, man?”, Sero asked, frowning up at him in confusion. Katsuki squinted his eyes at him in annoyance.

“The *fuck* do you think it is? Didn’t we fucking go to the mall yesterday to get Shitty Hair his birthday gifts?”

Sero's frown deepened and he sat up straight on the couch so that he could have a better look at Katsuki.

"Dude, *that* was what we were there for?", he asked, clearly surprised.

"Ooh, no", Izuku mumbled quietly from where he was standing beside Katsuki and grimacing in sympathy for Sero's fate after those words. Katsuki, on the other hand, merely stared down at him, his silent manner more frightening than his explosive one.

"Of fucking course it was; the hell did you think we were doing there?", he asked after a few seconds, as if he was trying his best not to go berserk and murder Sero on the spot.

"I don't know! You didn't tell us anything! All you said was for us to follow you and then you stormed out as usual! We just chased after!"

A tense pause.

"So you're fucking telling me you guys spent all that fucking time inside the damn mall and you didn't get Kirishima a single birthday present?"

Sero held up his hands in front of him as if to signal his surrender.

"Dude, we didn't even have our wallets on us. We legit just followed you out –"

"And why the *fuck* didn't any of you damn morons take the time to ask me about what the fuck we were doing in the damn mall in the middle of a Sunday fucking morning in the first place?"

"Did you even *look* at yourself in a mirror yesterday, Bakugou? You were clearly pissed off at something and we didn't want to get our asses exploded by asking you questions!"

"God fucking damn it, I can't believe this shit", Katsuki pinched the bridge of his nose impatiently between two fingers and closed his eyes, looking like he was trying his best not to lose his crap. Izuku could see smoke starting to erupt from one of his hands. Taking a deep breath that wasn't exactly calming but that prevented him from blowing Sero up, he continued: "Fine, *ok*. At what time is Shitty Hair supposed to arrive?"

"Uh, I don't know anything – Uh, Mina", Sero called over to where Mina was sitting on the top of Kaminari's back and holding him in a chokehold. "What time is Kiri arriving again?"

"In two hours! He went out with the guys as a distraction!", she shouted, not letting go of the struggling Kaminari, who was desperately slamming his hand on the floor as if to indicate his surrender.

"Good", Katsuki said, looking angrier than ever as he fished his wallet out of his back pocket and grabbed a handful of money. He threw it at Sero's lap as if it was nothing, glaring down at him. "That gives your ugly ass more than enough time to head down to the damn mall and buy something nice for Shitty Hair".

Sero stared at the money on his lap, then up at Katsuki, then at the money again. He looked extremely confused.

“The hell am I supposed to get him, a diamond ring? This is way too much money, man”, he protested, looking a mixture of surprised and horrified that Katsuki would have that much cash on him. Katsuki, on his own turn, rolled his eyes with impatience, while Izuku watched the exchange from up close and stared at Katsuki’s face with a mixture of curiosity and sadness.

“I don’t give a shit what you fucking buy him, just make sure you get a gift from you, Dunce Face and Raccoon Eyes”, Katsuki spat dismissively, crossing his arms above his chest.

“Stop pretending you don’t know our names!”, Mina shouted from somewhere in the distance.

“And take the damn idiot with you, while you’re at it”, Katsuki pointed at Kaminari, who had just been released from Mina’s grasp and was lying face-first on the floor, panting. “Buy the missing snacks for the party too. I’ll see if I can do something as a safe measure in case you two are too incompetent to do even that”, he scoffed.

“A-Are you sure about this? I mean…”, Sero said uncomfortably, holding the money in his hands as if he was afraid to touch it. “This… This is a whole lot of money. Where did you even get it from?”

“It’s none of your *damn* business”, Katsuki snarled angrily. “Just pay me back later when you assholes finally find your ways to your damn wallets”, he spat and, before Sero could offer any further resistance, he walked away, heading to the kitchen.

“Move over, Sugar Guy”, he said impolitely, grabbing a pan and setting it on the top of the stove with a loud bang before Sato could even make sense of his presence there. Upon the boy’s confused look, Katsuki said, at the same time he grabbed a bunch of ingredients from the common fridge: “I assume you’re making the sweets for Shitty Hair’s party, so I’ll deal with the salty food. Just stay the hell out of my way and don’t piss me off like those assholes did”, he nodded at Mina, Kaminari, and Sero, who were reunited in the common room and sending Katsuki weird looks. “I’m not in a good fucking mood today”.

Sato frowned at him.

“But Mina said you wouldn’t be coo–“

“Well, does it *look* like I’m not fucking cooking to you?”, Katsuki interrupted him abruptly, putting on the first apron he could get his hands on and grabbing a knife from the counter. Without wasting any time, he began to chop the vegetables he had grabbed, as quickly, furiously, and proficiently as he always did, never breaking eye contact with Sato as he did so. Sato swallowed dry and averted his eyes.

“Kacchan, you’re being rude to Sato-san”, Izuku pointed out as Sato quietly took a preventive step away from Katsuki and resumed preparing the cover for the cake that was sitting on the counter.

“So what?”, Katsuki grunted, continuing to chop the vegetables and completely ignoring the fact that he was talking to someone Sato couldn’t see or hear.

“So… You shouldn’t be”.

“I’m not going to ask you why the fuck not, so don’t bother telling me”.

“He’s cooking for Kirishima-kun’s party”.

“So am *I*, shitty Deku”.

“Yes, but… They’re not even that close to each other. He has no reason to be doing it, so maybe just be… nice to him?”

“I don’t know what the fuck you’re talking about. Kirishima is close to every fucking person in this damn place. I bet there isn’t a single soul he hasn’t fucking said hi to”, Katsuki scoffed. “This asshole’s baking the cake because he fucking wants to. No one’s making him do it”, he nodded at Sato without looking at him, at the same time he began chopping the vegetables down with more intensity, as if to make his annoyance clear.

Sato took another preventive step to the side, dragging his pan along with him. He was staring at Katsuki as if he had completely lost his mind, even though he was well aware that Izuku was there, no matter how invisible. Izuku, on the other hand, simply rolled his eyes and climbed on the counter right behind the stove, sitting there with his legs dangling above the floor and staring at Katsuki face-to-face.

“Still, it doesn’t mean you shouldn’t be nice to him. He’s doing something nice for your friend”.

“He’s your friend, too”.

A pause.

“What?”

“Shitty Hair. He’s your friend, too. Like I fucking said, he’s friends with anyone that as much as breathes near him. And you always talk as if he’s just *my* friend”.

Izuku blushed.

“Fine. He’s doing something nice for *our* friend. Also, I think you’re making Sato-san uncomfortable, so maybe this is not the best moment for us to have this conversation?”, he suggested deflectively.

“There is nothing to have a conversation about, asshole”, Katsuki said just as he abruptly turned his head to the side to stare at Sato, who had his eyes glued on his own pan in a (failed) attempt to look like he wasn’t paying any attention on Katsuki talking to their invisible classmate. “Oi. You got a problem with me talking to Deku around you?”, he asked, more assertively than he probably intended.

“*Kacchan*”, Izuku sighed in embarrassment, covering his face with one of his hands.

“What? You’re the one who fucking said he was getting uncomfortable”, Katsuki justified, staring back at Izuku, and then at Sato again. The boy had blushed, his eyes darting between Katsuki and the empty space where he assumed Izuku must have been standing (he didn’t get it right). “I’m only asking because if you *do* have a problem, then feel free to get the fuck off my kitchen and leave me to cook on my own –“

“This is not your kitchen, Kacchan“.

“Oh my fucking god, can you stop fucking meddling in all my conversations for once?”

“I wouldn’t have to meddle if you didn’t act so rude!“

“I’m not being rude, I’m being honest –“

“ – You’re just driving Sato-san away because you feel threatened!”

A pregnant pause.

“Uh, I’m not uncomfortable, man, I’m actually just finishing this. It’ll only take like, five more minutes to get ready, then I have to add the icing but I can do that by the counter if you’re gonna need the space –“

“The fuck did you just say?”

A hesitant pause.

“Uh, I said that I can do it by the counter –“

“Not you. *You*”, Katsuki pointed at Izuku with his knife. Izuku stared at Katsuki with an untroubled expression, as if he didn’t feel threatened at all by a knife he knew that couldn’t touch him.

“You and I both know that Sato-san’s cooking is amazing, but you have to be the best at everything as usual, so he’s making you feel threatened. Especially because he’s cooking for Kirishima-kun”, Izuku explained as it was very simple to understand. Katsuki opened his mouth to scream a series of curses and protests, but before he could even say anything, Izuku added: “Don’t even try to deny it, Kacchan. I can feel what you feel, remember?”

Katsuki growled dangerously low in his throat.

“And in case you *don’t* remember”, he said angrily through gritted teeth, “You don’t know *shit* about me just because of that, so keep your damn opinion to yourself”.

Izuku sighed.

“I don’t know why you’re in such a sour mood today”.

“It’s none of your damn business”.

“I mean, your mood is usually sour, but today it’s worse”.

“Stop fucking talking”.

“See? I thought you’d gotten used to that already”.

“As if anyone could ever get fucking used to your damn rambling”.

“Is it because of the party? Are you nervous too?”

“I ain’t fucking nervous about anything, you damn fucking nerd –“

“I think you are, though”.

“You *think* a whole damn lot”.

A chuckle.

“Yeah”.

“Then keep it for yourself”.

“It’s ok to be nervous. I know Kirishima-kun is important to you”.

“Why the fuck would I fucking be nervous about that?”

“Because it’s a surprise party, and you want everything to go right”.

“Wanting shit to go right doesn’t mean I have to be nervous about it”.

“Yes, but Kaminari-kun didn’t buy the food and no one got any gifts. So now you’re trying to organize everything, but Kirishima-kun could end up arriving sooner than he should and the surprise would be ruined”.

“What a negative piece of shit you are”.

“I’m just saying what I think you’re feeling”.

“Even though I didn’t fucking ask you”.

“You never ask me”.

A pregnant, awkward pause.

“What I mean is… you don’t have to worry”.

“Funny you should say that right *after* making me a fucking list of everything that can go wrong”.

“But you *don’t* have to worry, Kacchan!”, a chuckle. “I’m sure Kirishima-kun will love the party, even if everything does go wrong”.

“Of *course* he fucking will. The guy is basically a human puppy who gets excited over anything. He’ll be happy just because we even considered throwing him a damn party”.

A sad smile.

“See? You don’t have to take your stress out on Sato-san. Everything will turn out fine”.

“I’m not taking anything out on anyone”.

“Then why are you so grumpy?”

“I’ve already said it’s none of your damn fucking business!”

“I can tell there’s something bothering you!”

“So fucking what?”

“So I want to help!”

“Keep your help to your fucking self!”

“Fine!”

“Fucking finally!”

Silence fell on the kitchen. Katsuki turned his head and found that Sato had moved to the kitchen table, as if to give him and Deku some privacy. He tried to feel embarrassed by that – and by the fact that he had been so distracted by Deku that he didn’t even see the guy move away – but failed.

Deku continued to watch him cook without saying anything, and without meeting Katsuki’s eyes, either. Back at the common room, Sero and Kaminari left to buy Kirishima’s gifts and more food, whereas Mina and Hagakure started to put up the decoration. Sato, who finished with the cake more quickly than Katsuki had expected him to (not that the thought made him jealous or angry) decided to go give the girls a hand, since the last thing he probably wanted was to stay in the kitchen with a screaming, angry Katsuki.

Katsuki poured some sausages inside a large pot with boiling water at the same time he stirred the pan where he was cooking the seasoning for the tomato sauce, which was being heated up in a third pot. Deku watched in silence as Katsuki managed all two pots and the pan at the same time, paying sharp attention in each step he took to make the hot-dogs for the party. This wasn’t his usual go-to choice of food, but he didn’t have much time to cook anything better and cooking dinner would be too formal for the party of someone like Kirishima. Either way, the hot-dogs were supposed to be a filler food, just in case the pair of Katsuki’s buffoon friends didn’t manage to buy any more food for the party.

“Wow, Kacchan”, Izuku said after a while, finally breaking the silence and seemingly calling it a truce as Katsuki mixed the sauce and the seasoning. “This smells amazing”.

“Of course it fucking does, you damn nerd”, Katsuki grunted simply, hiding the proud smirk that was threatening to blossom on his lips. “I’m the one cooking it”.

Izuku said nothing else, even though there was a hint of humor on his lips.

It didn’t take much longer for the other members of Class 1-A to arrive gradually, but Katsuki didn’t bother to greet any of them (and they were all too scared to walk into the kitchen just to greet him). Once Ochako arrived, Mina and Hagakure asked her to help hang the Happy Birthday sign on the wall using her quirk, to which she promptly complied, and Katsuki was relieved to see that not only Round Face, but also Frog Girl, Four Eyes, Bird Brain and Earphone Girl had brought gifts with them. They had set the bags right beside Katsuki’s (which was, to his pride, the largest one) on the floor, which meant thank fuck, Kirishima wasn’t about to get only one birthday gift. Not that he cared about that or anything.

Everyone helped Mina with the final decorations as they arrived, and, soon enough, from the sound of it, all of Class 1-A was there. Hell, it seemed even some people from Class 1-B were there as well – the Redundant Steel Guy and Big Hands were the only one Katsuki managed to spot from the kitchen, but from the way Kirishima was social, he knew there were probably more of them.

“Kirishima-kun does have a lot of friends”, Deku commented from where he was still sitting on the counter, staring at the common room and all the people interacting there. Katsuki was almost done with the hot-dogs – the sausages and the sauce had already been mixed and just needed to boil for a little longer before he could put them on the breads.

“Fucking tell me about it”, Katsuki grunted simply, not looking at the ghost boy as he stirred the pot. “It’s annoying, most of the time”.

“I think it’s nice that he’s getting a surprise party”, Deku continued pensively. “He deserves it. He’s – he’s nice”.

“Hm”, was all Katsuki could respond. He had no idea where Deku was trying to get with that talk, but he wasn’t in the mood to lead him on. He would already have to interact with a whole bunch of people that night (which was something he was rarely up to, and that he only ever did for Kirishima’s sake) and he had started his day with a mood more sour than usual.

He wasn’t sure what had caused him to be so grumpy – the dream that had been plaguing his mind for a couple days now, the fact that he and Deku hadn’t touched ever since, or the fact that he would have to sit through hours of social interaction. Perhaps it was a mixture of all those three factors.

Whatever it was, Katsuki knew that it was very unlikely he would last through the night without blowing someone up, since he was already *this* pissed off and the party hadn’t even started yet.

“Ay, Bakubro!”, Mina greeted as she walked into the kitchen. Her face was flushed and slightly sweaty from the effort of getting everything ready for Kiri’s arrival, but there was a pleased, sincere smile on her face. She opened the fridge and grabbed a few beer bottles before closing the door and walking over to Katsuki.

“Told you to fucking stop calling me that”, was Katsuki’s angry response.

“Ah, so you’re in a mood today. Are the hot-dogs almost ready?”, she leaned over his shoulder, trying to take a look at the pot.

“If you want them to get done faster –“, he snarled, but Mina interrupted him.

“Oh, *shush*, you little angry pepper. I’m not rushing you; I just want to know. Kiri’s about to arrive any minute now”, she explained.

“And why the fuck should I care?”

“Because this is literally his party, Bakugou, jeez”, Mina rolled her eyes. Then, before Katsuki could do anything about it, she was shoving one of the beer bottles into his free hand. “Here, have one. You look like you could use it”.

“The hell is that supposed to mean?”, he asked angrily as he walked away from him and out the kitchen.

“It means you need to chill, Bakubro!”, she waved her own bottle at him. “And maybe live a little! That will certainly help you!”

Katsuki rolled his eyes, waiting until Mina was out of sight in order to crack the beer bottle open. As much as he would never admit it to her face, the girl was right – he really could use a fucking beer on that moment.

Katsuki wasn’t exactly experienced in drinking or anything, but he couldn't say he hadn't already tried beer a couple times. The first time had been pretty pathetic, if he had to be honest: his mom offered it to him during his 15th birthday party. Katsuki could still remember this as one of the only instances in which his father lost his temper, his face red and angry as he yelled at the old hag. She had shrugged his freak-out session off with a simple “I’d rather he tries this shit at home than on the streets with those brats he calls his friends” before taking the cup from Katsuki’s hands.

The second time was on the streets with the brats he called his friends, because he was a hot-headed idiot who couldn’t hear a mocking “I bet you can’t do it” without trying to prove himself. He couldn’t say he liked the bitter taste of beer, but he still drank it in one go.

Those had been his only contacts with the drink, and Katsuki had to admit he didn’t really miss it or enjoy it so much as some people seemed to do. He didn’t really like the way it made him feel lightheaded and tipsy, or the way it made him forget things afterwards; the alcohol upset his senses and his coherence, which were things he valued greatly. Now that he thought back at it, he could see how fucking pathetic and stupid he had been; 15, drinking cheap booze at a back alley with two extras whose names he didn’t even know anymore, just because he had been challenged. How cringy.

And the memory was also a reminder that everything he took for granted back then was gone now. All the things that had seemed so important were reduced to nothing in the face of the new challenges he was dealing with.

If he had told his 15-year-old self that he would end up cuddling with Deku on his own bed and out of his free will in the future… the young version of him would have probably kicked his ass.

God, he'd been such an asshole.

And you're not even sorry, are you?

If he had to be honest, forgetting shit and feeling light for a while didn't sound like such a bad idea anymore. Which was why he opened the bottle in the first place.

"Kacchan… what are you doing?", Izuku asked, sounding like he was actually horrified as Katsuki took a sip of the cold beer.

"The fuck does it look like I'm doing?", he asked in a deadpan, holding the bottle with one hand and going back to stirring the pot with his other.

"You can't do that! You're underage!", Izuku pointed out, nervous. He was speaking in a high-pitched, whispered voice, as if he was afraid anyone other than Katsuki might hear him. He hopped off the counter and approached Katsuki with wide, disapproving eyes.

"You tell that to the ones who bought the booze in the first place", Katsuki replied simply, taking another sip just to rile Deku up. "Also, I'm just a few years away from being legally allowed to drink".

"A few years is a lot!", Deku said, exasperated.

"What, you think I'll think any fucking differently in a few years than I think now?", Katsuki rolled his eyes. "Get off my dick. It's not like I've never drank this shit before".

"*Kacchan*!"

"Shut up, Deku. Your non-stop rambling is one of the fucking reasons I'm drinking this shit", he took another sip, now more out of spite than out of an actual desire to get drunk. Maybe he hadn't changed all that much from when he had been 15, after all.

"Hey, don't try to put this on me!"

"I wouldn't *have* to if you kept your fucking trap shut for more than five minutes".

"You were just complaining I was too quiet earlier!"

"Because you were acting weird".

"No, I wasn't!"

"Yes, you fucking were".

"You're the one who's been acting weird these past few days!"

A pause, followed by a frown.

“The fuck are you talking about?”

“I – I don’t know”, Izuku hesitated, sounding as if he hadn’t meant to approach that subject. “You’ve been… different”.

“The hell do you mean, different?”

“I don’t know! You’ve been weird around me!”

Katsuki rolled his eyes with impatience.

“God, do you plan on making me ask the same fucking question a million fucking times over? Just fucking *spit it out* already, nerd!”

“I don’t know how to explain it!”

“Put some damn effort into it, then!”

“It’s just – you’ve –“, Izuku paused and took a deep breath, remembering how Katsuki hated it whenever he stuttered too much. He took a few moments to organize his thoughts before continuing. “Ever since we… Well, ever since we hugged. And then – you’ve been weird. Like you don’t want to touch me. And – you’ve been giving me these weird looks…”

Katsuki held his breath, but tried his best to keep a neutral face lest Deku notice his reaction. It was true that, ever since the nightmare, he’d been checking out on Deku more often, almost as if to reassure himself that the boy was still alive… But he hadn’t expected the damn nerd to notice it. Hell, he couldn’t even begin to *explain* it to him.

“I – I know I’ve already said this, but sorry if I made you uncomfortable”, Izuku continued when Katsuki didn’t say anything. “I was just trying to help. If – If that’s why you’re weird, then… sorry?”

Katsuki didn’t meet his eyes. He didn’t know what to fucking say to that.

(He couldn’t say the truth, so it was better to stay silent).

“I… I didn’t mean to overstep a boundary”, Izuku added more quietly after a few prolonged moments of silence. Looking at him, Katsuki scoffed at the guilty, miserable look painting his face.

“You know the world doesn’t revolve around your fucking giant head, right, nerd?”, he said, sounding angry. Deku looked up at him. “God, you’ve always thought so fucking much of yourself”.

Deku frowned.

“So… I’m not the reason why you’re acting weird?”

“I’m not acting fucking weird. You’re just making up stuff”.

Deku gave him a worried look.

“I don’t think so, Kacchan”.

“As I’ve said a hundred times over, I don’t give a single rat’s ass what you think”.

“You’ve been different”.

“Different *how*?”

“Quieter. And… more pensive? This is the first time I’ve seen you angry in days, and I don’t even know what triggered it”.

“The bunch of assholes standing right over there talking loudly as if they were fucking animals is what triggered it. Is that sorted out in your monkey brain now?”

“I don’t think that’s just it”.

“And I don’t –“

“You don’t care what I think, I *know*. But there’s something else to it. I can tell”.

“Because you’re the supreme asshole with the genius-level intellect who always knows what’s best for every fucking one, right?”

“Uh, no. Because I can feel what you feel”.

“That doesn’t mean anything”.

“I think it does”.

“If you tell me what you think one more damn time, I’m going to try that sock theory and see how many of them I can shove down your fucking throat until you shut up”.

“See? Grumpy”.

“That’s just my usual mood”.

A chuckle.

“Yeah, I suppose it is”.

“Shut up”.

“Still, I think it’s pretty surprising that you go to sleep at 8 p.m. but think it’s ok to drink beer”.

“Now, you listen here, you cocky little *asshole* –“

“Shhh! Guys!”, Mina interrupted everyone in the common room – and in the kitchen – with a hissed whisper, madly gesturing at Katsuki for him to approach. “Kiri is arriving! Everyone, stay quiet! Bakugou, get your ass over here!”

“I ain’t about to let all this fucking effort go to waste just because you assholes care more about making a surprise than for the fucking food”, Katsuki grunted. “I’ll get my ass over there when the damn hot-dog is ready”.

“Stop being such an ass and get here! He’s about to come in!”, she added in a high-pitched, urgent whisper, turning the lights off in order to increase the surprise effect and crouching down on the floor behind the couch, right beside Uraraka and Jirou. Once she was settled, she turned towards Katsuki and began gesturing for him to approach again.

“Revelry in the dark…”, Tokoyami commented quietly as soon as Mina turned the lights off.

“I said I’ll get my fucking ass over there when the fucking food is ready!“, Katsuki said in his normal tone of voice.

“*Shh*! Everyone has to be here for the surprise!”, Mina protested.

“If you had fucking supervised Dumb Pikachu with the food instead of leaving it for the last minute, I wouldn’t have to be fucking cooking –“

“Stop arguing and just get your ass here for a second –“

“*Guys, he’s here*!”

“I’d like to see you fucking make me, Raccoon –“

“Shut up, you’re gonna ruin it –“

“*Shhh! Everyone, be quiet*!”

“Hey, why is it so dark –?“

“*SURPRISE!!!”*

The discussion was interrupted as Kirishima arrived at the dark common room in confusion, which resulted on all of Class 1-A – except for Katsuki – and the guests from Class 1-B to jump to their feet to announce the surprise. Kirishima’s eyes widened as he realized that everyone was there, and when someone turned the lights back on and he noticed the decoration, the balloons and the Happy Birthday sign hanging from the ceiling, his eyes teared up.

“Y-You guys…”, he said, shaking his head and taking a fist to his lips in an attempt to hide his cry-face.

“It’s ok to cry, Kiri!”, Mina exclaimed, the first to pull him into a tight hug.

“Yeah!”, Tetsutetsu tapped his shoulder while Mina continued to hug him. “Let it all out!”

“Bro… That’s so manly, bro…”, Kirishima sobbed, gesturing at the Happy Birthday sign (which was decorated with several flexing arms and dumbbells).

“Just like you, Kirishima-kun!”, Uraraka exclaimed, hugging Kirishima as well after Tetsutetsu enveloped the boy in a tight embrace. “Happy birthday!”

“You guys… You didn’t have to…”, he sniffed, wiping his tears away and smiling widely with emotion at everyone who was there.

“Of course we had! You’re our best boy!”, Mina said as Kirishima received several hugs from the rest of his friends.

“And you guys played me like a fool!”, Kirishima pointed an accusing finger at Shoji and Ojiro.

“Someone had to distract you”, Ojiro shrugged apologetically, offering Kirishima a small smile. “But it was worth it, wasn’t it?”

“Of course it was, man!”, Kirishima said, pulling the boy into a tight hug. “Thank you!”

“And we even got Bakubro to cook!”, Mina pointed out, pointing a finger at Katsuki, who was still at the kitchen. Katsuki scowled as everyone’s attention turned to him, but Kirishima took a hand to his chest and his eyes teared up again. He made his way over to the kitchen, emotion in his eyes, and pulled Katsuki into a tight, heartfelt hug.

Surprisingly, he didn’t feel bothered by that.

In fact, he… He felt pretty good. It was nice being hugged after… Well.

(He didn’t know why his chest felt so tight, though).

“Bakugou”, Kirishima said, breaking the hug and smiling at him. He kept a hand on Katsuki’s shoulder, squeezing it tightly. “Thank you, bro”, he nodded emphatically, as if to show he meant his words.

“Don’t thank *me*, Hair-For-Brains”, Katsuki rolled his eyes, even though there was affection etched in crimson. He still had an image to maintain, after all. “Thank Raccoon Eyes. She was the one who organized everything”.

“I don’t deserve all the credit”, Mina immediately said, leaning on the other side of the kitchen counter. “Everyone helped a bit!”

“Thank you, Mina”, Kirishima pulled her into another hug. “I really didn’t have it coming… I had no idea that – oh, my god, you guys are so amazing”, he wiped a few tears away again. “Where’s Kami and Sero?”, Kirishima asked, looking around the room in an attempt to find his friends.

“They’ll be here soon enough!”, Mina said dismissingly, as if not to reveal the true reason behind the boys’ absence. “Now, why don’t you go say hi to everyone else, huh? We can all

open your presents later!", she grabbed Kirishima by the forearm and pulled him back towards the living room, where his birthday gifts were all piled up.

"Oh my god, that's so many! You guys didn't have to!", Kirishima exclaimed when he spotted the number of bags and wrapped gifts. Katsuki spared the beaming boy one final look before going back to taking a sip of his beer and stirring the hot-dog sauce with a disinterested expression.

"Aren't you going to join them?", Izuku asked Katsuki with curiosity, standing beside him and watching closely what he was doing.

"Oh, sure, Deku", Katsuki scoffed. "Why don't I just fucking leave these hot-dogs over here and wait for the sausages to fucking jump on the breads by themselves, huh?"

Izuku stared at him for a long time as Katsuki began to cut the breads for the hot-dogs, a hurt expression in his eyes.

"You're being an asshole", he said simply before turning on his heels and walking away.

Katsuki sighed and grabbed Izuku by the forearm before the boy could leave the kitchen, and before he could really think about it.

Deku stared at him.

He glared at Deku.

They stared at each other for a long time, the tension between them building up.

The truth was… ever since the nightmare, the idea of Deku being upset at him – being angry, or resentful, or sad – bothered Katsuki to no end. It was like he couldn't stand the thought.

He couldn't stand to see anything close to accusation in his stupid, fucking green eyes.

He never paid much mind to Deku's admiration for him, but now that he knew there was a hypothetical chance of losing it forever, the idea terrified him. He wished he could tell or understand why.

This is your fault. And you're not even sorry, are you?

"I'm just stressed out", Katsuki justified, ending up sounding angrier than anything, even though a dark part of his brain hated himself for feeling the need to do so in the first place. "And the amount of people in here ain't making it easier. There's too many of them for my liking".

"Yeah", Izuku breathed out through his nose, looking upset still. "I know that".

"Don't fucking *act* like that", Katsuki scoffed, annoyed.

"You said you would let me have fun, even though I'm a ghost".

“Are you fucking charging me?”

“No. If anything, I’m just getting as stressed out as you are”.

Katsuki sighed, letting go of Izuku’s wrist.

“The fuck do you want me to say?”

“’Sorry for being rude to you for no reason’ would be a nice start”.

“You know I don’t do apologies”.

“Clearly”.

“You’re getting way too fucking sassy for my liking”.

“It’s not my fault your sarcasm keeps dripping into me”.

“Actually, it fucking is”.

Deku continued to stare at him, unfaltering in his resolve. He looked determined to get… *something* out of Katsuki, even though the latter couldn’t tell what it was. If he was hoping for an apology, he would have to wait forever. There was only so much Katsuki was willing to do for shitty Deku’s sake.

“I’m almost done with the damn hot-dogs. Then you can go and talk to your fucking friends, or whatever your idea of having fun is”, he waved a dismissing hand at him, going back to his business.

Izuku just stayed there, staring at him.

“Can you tell Kirishima-kun I wished him a happy birthday?”, he asked after a few moments, his tone almost testing.

“Fine”, Katsuki sighed, continuing to cut the breads.

“And that I’ll get him a birthday present as soon as I’m back in my body?”

“He doesn’t really care about that, to be real”.

“And that I’m sorry I can’t give him an actual hug right now –“

“Why don’t you just fucking write him a letter already?”, Katsuki cut him off before he could think about it.

Izuku sighed, lowering his head in silence.

Katsuki sighed as well. God *damn* it.

“*Fine*, shitty Deku. I’ll tell him all that crap”.

“Ok”.

“No ‘*thank you, Kacchan*’?”, he raised an eyebrow.

Izuku hesitated.

“If you don’t have to say ‘sorry’, then I don’t have to say ‘thank you’”.

“That’s rude as fuck”.

“Oh, and you’re not, Kacchan?”

“I’m *allowed* to be rude”.

“What does that even mean?”, Izuku ended up chuckling.

“It means I’m fucking allowed to be rude. It’s just my personality”.

“Uh, that’s not how it works, actually. And that’s a terrible excuse”.

“Shut up. I get to be rude. You don’t get to be impolite”.

“I don’t think so”.

“I’ll kick your ghost ass”.

“I’ll say ‘thank you’ if you say ‘sorry’”.

“I’ll say ‘sorry’ if you say my name”.

“*Kacchan*”.

“That’s not my name”.

“Stop mocking me”, he groaned, embarrassed.

“*Never*”.

“You’re mean”.

“That’s my charm”.

Izuku blushed. There was nothing he could possibly respond to that.

“I don’t want to be a fucking part of this”.

“Ah, come on, Bakubro! It will be fun!”

“I’m not drunk enough for this shit”.

“I can fix that for you”, Kaminari handed him another beer bottle.

“Kaminari-kun! I have already warned you to get rid of all remaining alcohol! This is not an acceptable behavior for UA students!”, Iida protested, for what must have been the sixth time that night.

“I won’t tell if you don’t, big guy!”, Kaminari, who was tipsy already, raised his bottle at Iida before downing half of it in one large gulp.

“Kaminari-kun! Stop drinking that right now! As class representative –“

“Have some fun, Iida-kun!”, Kaminari threw an arm around Iida’s shoulders, leaning heavily on him and making them both lose balance. “Ohh, that rhymed!”, he exclaimed, excited, as Iida helped him get his footing back. “Yo, Sero! Sero, I’m a poet!”, he shouted at his friend, giggling madly and throwing all his weight against Iida, who supported the drunk boy with stern patience.

Sero, who was sitting with Mina and Kendo on the couch, simply raised his own bottle at Kaminari, probably not understanding one single word he was saying but cheering him anyway. Iida took the distraction to remove the bottle from Kaminari’s hand and unceremoniously pour the remaining contents (which weren’t much) down the kitchen sink.

“Nooooo! My booze!”, Kaminari protested, but was too dizzy to retrieve the bottle from the taller boy before all the beer was gone. Iida carefully led Kaminari back to the circle of friends who were sitting on the floor in the middle of the common room, helping him sit down and taking his side in order to keep an eye on him.

Katsuki, on the other hand, took the time in which Iida handled Kaminari to down the remains of his own beer. He was one of the members of the circle on the floor, sitting right between Kirishima and Jirou. Deku was sitting between Jirou and Katsuki, even though only the latter could see the boy. Jirou had politely asked Izuku if he wanted her to move to the side in order to give him some space to sit, and now they were all arranged neatly on the floor. Other members of the circle included Uraraka, Kaminari and Iida, who seemed to be having an argument about responsibility, Icy Hot (reluctantly), Tetsutetsu, and Hagakure.

“Ok, can we get started, guys?”, Kirishima asked, placing an empty bottle at the center of the circle.

“Do I really have to be part of this?”, Katsuki sighed, rolling his eyes in deep annoyance.

“Come on, bro! Midoriya can’t play unless you do!”, Sero pointed out for what must have been the millionth time, raising a suggestive eyebrow at Katsuki, who sighed in resignation.

“What fucking ever. If this gets too boring, I’ll leave”, he warned simply, taking another sip of his booze.

“Bakugou-kun! You shouldn’t be drinking that either!”, Iida protested, looking like he was about to try and take the bottle away from him. Katsuki simply glared at him.

“You try to take this off me, I’ll blow your glass collection up”, he said matter-of-factly.

“All right, here we go!”, Kirishima spun the bottle before another argument could start. Iida glared back at Katsuki, disapproval written all over his eyes, but he did not interrupt the game for Kirishima’s sake. The bottle slowly came to a stop and ended up pointing at Hagakure and Jirou. “Nice! Jirou, truth or dare?”, he asked.

Jirou looked a bit embarrassed, as if she wasn’t sure which was the least terrifying option.

“Uh, truth”, she shrugged. None of them could see it, but from the sound of it, Hagakure was clapping her hands in excitement.

“Do you have a crush on anyone from our class?”, Hagakure asked without missing a beat, as if she had been storing that question for a long time. Jirou immediately blushed.

“Ooooh!”, Kaminari teased drunkenly, toppling to the side and onto Iida, who looked annoyed but still supported the boy. “Hagakure-san asking the real questions here!”

“The game started out spicy!”, Uraraka joined in.

“Come on, Jirou! Spit it out!”, Kirishima encouraged. Jirou’s blush deepened and she lowered her head.

“Y-Yeah”, she said in a voice so low that barely anyone heard it.

“Who?! Who is it?!”, Hagakure immediately shrieked.

“You only get to ask one question at the time!”, Jirou protested, sounding way too defensive, face still flushed.

“Aaaah, that’s not fair!”, Hagakure wailed in disappointment.

“Ok, Jirou, your turn!”, Kirishima told her, pointing to the bottle. She twisted it around, and it pointed to Iida and Uraraka.

“Ok, Iida, you shoot the question!”, Kirishima instructed. Iida straightened himself up with a solemn air and pushed his glasses up the bridge of his nose before addressing his best friend.

“Uraraka-san!”, he exclaimed loudly, way more formally than he should have. “Do you prefer truth or dare?”

“Uuh, truth!”, Uraraka responded promptly, leaning forwards with excitement.

“What is your preferred school subject?”

“Whaaaat?”, Kaminari slurred.

“Uh… That’s – That’s not how you play…”, Kirishima looked like he wanted to explain, but didn’t want to make Iida embarrassed at the same time.

“Oh, Iida-kun…”, Hagakure lamented with something akin to disappointment in her tone.

“You gotta ask something personal, man!”, Kaminari stepped in, drunkenly leaning over Iida yet again. “Here, lemme show you. Ayy, Uraraka – who in this circle would you rather smooch?”

“*Eeeeeeeeeeeh*?!”, Uraraka shrieked, eyes widening and cheeks burning a bright red immediately.

“Ghosts don’t count, huh?”, Kaminari added, giggling like crazy and giving Uraraka an exaggerated wink before nudging at Iida with his elbow. Everyone in the circle muttered in protest and second-hand embarrassment for Kaminari’s drunken antics, and Jirou used her earphone jack to electrocute him as a warning, making the boy yelp in surprise and pain. Uraraka covered her flushed face with her hands, which in turn resulted on her floating away from the circle and towards the top of the ceiling.

“Look what you’ve done, *baka*!”, Jirou reprehended.

“Kaminari-kun! This disrespectful behavior is shameful!”, Iida exclaimed, indignant.

“Uraraka-san! Come back!”, Hagakure wailed.

“Yo, Sero! Sero, my man!”, Kirishima called.

“Yeah, dude?”, Sero responded from the couch.

“Come here fix Kaminari! He’s too far gone, man!”, Kirishima requested, waving urgently. Sero got up and walked over to the circle of friends, Mina and Kendo coming along with him to see what the buzz was all about.

“Nooooo”, Kaminari cried drunkenly as Sero began to prepare the tape, trying to use the reluctant Iida as a human shield from his friend. “I promise I’ll behave!”

“Sorry, man”, Sero shrugged apologetically, wrapping Kaminari’s arms and legs up with his tape and dragging him away from the circle as if he was a sack of potatoes. “You’re done for the night . Go take a nap and stop embarrassing yourself, ok?”, he suggested, dragging Kaminari towards the time-out corner, where Mineta was already completely cocooned in tape and glued to the wall away from view.

“This is why there should be no alcohol in this party! This is against the law!”, Iida continued to protest, gesturing with his hands.

“Ah, live a little, Iida-kun!”, Hagakure nudged at him playfully with one invisible elbow. “Have you even tried the drinks yet?”

“Of course not, Hagakure-san! As class representative, it would be disgraceful for me to break the rules, especially since we are all underage! If anything, my duty is to inform Aizawa sensei of this immediately!”

“Nooo!”, came an immediate chorus of protests.

Sero and Mina were still trying to get Uraraka to come down from the ceiling, Sero trying to catch the floating girl with his tape, while Kirishima, Hagakure and Iida entered a heated discussion about responsibility and laws. Soon enough, the truth or dare game was dispersed, and only Katsuki and Izuku were still sitting on the floor, Katsuki nursing his beer and watching as Iida insisted on calling their teacher and ruining the party.

“This fucking sucks, man”, Katsuki growled to no one and nothing in particular, taking another sip. He looked at Deku, who was staring up at Uraraka with a worried expression.

“Someone should help her down”, Izuku commented pensively. “Uraraka has trouble handling her nausea if she uses her quirk for too long, and she can’t just release without risking an injury now that she’s so high up”.

Katsuki huffed out a breath and took another sip of the beer before turning to Deku again.

“What’s your deal with her, anyway?”, he asked, staring at the boy. Izuku blushed.

“W-What? W-What do you mean?!”

“Your deal with Round Face. She clearly has the hots for you”.

“Kacchan! Don’t say things like that!”

“Oh, come on. Everyone can fucking see it. Look at her reaction just because of Dunce Face’s teasing”.

Izuku’s face became even redder and he looked away.

“S-She’s… She’s my friend. Only that”.

Katsuki stared at him, a mixture of feelings in his chest. He took another sip, well aware that he wouldn’t be able to figure out what effect Deku’s words had caused on him anyway.

“If you say so”, he shrugged with indifference, going back to staring at their arguing friends with disinterest.

“Are you… Are you sure you should be drinking this much?”, Izuku asked after a few moments of silence.

Katsuki scowled at him as if Deku was the most stupid person he had ever encountered.

“The fuck do you mean? This is only my second beer”.

“Uh, yes…? That’s why I’m asking?”

“If you think two beer bottles is too much, you’re more of a nerd than I thought”.

Izuku’s fingers played with the hem of his shirt and he hesitated.

“It’s just…”

Katsuki sighed, rolling his eyes in impatience.

“*What*?”

“I’m starting to feel a bit tipsy”.

A pregnant pause.

“*What*?”

Izuku looked away from him, embarrassed.

“Oh my god. Oh my fucking *god*”.

“Kacchan”.

“I didn’t think this shit would affect you”.

“Well, it’s only natural it would, right?”

“There ain’t nothing natural about this shitty situation, Deku”.

A chuckle.

“Yeah, I suppose you’re right. But still… I think that if I can be happy when you eat katsudon, then I can also get drunk when you drink beer”.

“Which gives me hundreds of amazing ideas for what we’re doing the rest of the night”.

“*What*?”

“What?”

“What do you *mean*?”

“Well, what the fuck do you think I mean? I’m getting you shitfaced”.

“*What*?!”

“Oh, shut the fuck up”.

“Kacchan, I don’t want to get – *that*!”

“Why the hell not? Have you ever gotten shitfaced before?”

“Of course not!”

“Then you don’t know if you don’t want it”.

“Oh, I *do* know that I don’t want it!”

“You don’t know shit”.

“Have *you* ever gotten shitfaced?”

“Hah. I made you say it”.

“Oh my *god*”.

“But no, I haven’t. I don’t get drunk. This shit”, he waved the bottle, “only makes me lightheaded, tops. But not drunk”.

“Uh, that doesn’t sound right”.

“The fuck do you mean?”

“Well… I have an emotional connection with the katsudon, so it makes sense that you don’t feel anything particularly strong for it when you eat it, but I feel happy. Alcohol doesn’t work like that. The effect it has is purely biological, so it doesn’t make sense that I’m feeling tipsy and you’re not”.

“All that bullshit could make sense, but you’re not taking into consideration that some people can handle stupidly insane amounts of alcohol and be okay, while others”, he poked Deku’s chest, “get wasted after two bottles”.

“But I –“

“You wanna bet?”

“*What*?”

“You wanna bet I can get you shitfaced without even losing my fucking balance?”

“Uh, *no*. Not everything has to be a competition, Kacchan. Also, where did that talk about keeping your physical form go?”

“It’s not like a few bottles of beer are going to fuck me up. *Also* also, I’m willing to sacrifice one day of workouts just to see you fall on your face because you’re a pathetic lightweight”.

“*Kacchan*”.

“Are you up for it or not, chicken?”.

“Don’t call me chicken!”

“You’re a chicken if you say no”.

“That’s not how it works!”

“Well, I’m the one who makes the fucking rules. It’s my damn beer. And I say you’re a coward if you refuse”.

“This has nothing to do with courage!”

“Of course it fucking has. You’re a wimp”.

“Stop saying that!”

“Is it really that damaging to your fucking ego to say yes?”

“I don’t want to get shitfaced!”

“Why not? No one will be able to see it. This is the best possible scenario to get shitfaced in the history of fucking mankind”.

“But – But –!”

“You should be fucking glad that I’m willing to do you this favor”.

“How is *getting me drunk* a favor?”

“This way you won’t keep moping beside me, and I’ll get to chill out for the first time in fucking weeks. At the end of the day, we’ll both win”.

“It still sounds like you’re the only one getting anything out of this”.

“Shut up. If you’re already tipsy from two beers, I bet I can make you shit yourself in less than ten minutes”.

“Stop saying stuff like that!”

“Make me”.

Izuku hesitated, looking like he wanted to argue but didn’t know what to say.

“T-This…! This isn’t healthy!”

“That’s a wimpy excuse”.

“I don’t think this is a good idea!”

“I don’t care what you think. Also, didn’t you fucking say you wanted to have *fun*?”

“I don’t need alcohol to have fun!”

“Yeah? Then why are you so stiff and quiet and not ramming my fucking ear with requests to say stuff to people like I’m your fucking delivery boy?”

“I thought you wanted me to be quiet!”

“Since when do you fucking do what I want you to do?”

“Kacchan”, he held Katsuki’s wrist just as he cracked a third beer bottle open. “You’re way too excited about this”, he said, studying Katsuki’s face with a mixture of curiosity, apprehension and concern.

“Look”, Katsuki said, as seriously as he could. “It’s already a fucking miracle I haven’t blown anyone’s asses up with all this screaming and arguing that’s going around over here”.

“Yes”.

“You said you want to have fun, but you ain’t getting any of that if we’re both fucking sober. People stress me the fuck out. Not being with people stresses you the fuck out. I think we both have to fucking compromise here”.

“Kacchan…”

“Shut up”, he downed a large gulp of the beer, never breaking eye contact with Izuku. “And trust me”.

“I trust you”, Izuku shook his head slightly. “I’m just worried”.

“Don’t be. I can hold my beer”.

Izuku stared at him, looking like that wasn’t what he had meant.

I’m worried what I might say or do if I’m not in control.

“Plus, the alcohol is going into my body, not yours, so live a fucking little”, Katsuki added, unaware of Izuku’s inner crisis. “Take this as my proper thank you for you putting your ass on the line for me that one time”, he added, aware that, if he had been completely sober, he would have never said something of the kind straight to Deku’s face.

This is your fault. And you’re not even sorry, are you?

Izuku was looking at him with uncertain eyes.

“I told you I was gonna show you some real fun, Deku. And I’m a man of my fucking word”.

Izuku sighed.

What was the worst that could happen, anyway?

At least Kacchan looked excited. Maybe he could set his fears aside and be a bit excited, too, right? Maybe they could actually have some fun, even if just for a night?

“Fine”, Izuku willingly gave into the buzz.

Half an hour passed before he ended up bumping on the invisible girl for the fourth time that night.

“Ah, sorry, Bakugou-kun! I should have worn brighter clothes today!”

“Do you always have an excuse on the tip of your tongue?”, Katsuki scoffed at her.

“Yep!”

“But you’re not the one bumping into people. People are bumping into you”.

From the way the tank top floated, Katsuki assumed she was shrugging.

“If I don’t apologize, people will just keep shoving me around!”

Huh.

Was that why shitty Deku apologized so much about everything?

Hagakure turned on her heels and walked away, talking cheerfully with Ojiro as she went.

Staring at her, Katsuki had an idea.

He didn’t have a genius intellect for no reason.

“You assholes ready?”

“Yeah, man!”

“Ok!”

“You go!”

“All right, here we fucking go”.

Izuku giggled drunkenly and raised his arms up compliantly. Katsuki, who had gone all the way to his bedroom just to grab some of his clothes, shoved one of his shirts on Deku. As long as he kept his hand on the material, it shouldn’t phase through the ghost boy.

“So? What do you think?”, he asked his friends, who had all gathered up around them to watch, with the exception of Kaminari and Mineta, who were still tied up in a corner.

Hesitant silence.

“Uh… What exactly are we supposed to be seeing?”, Kirishima asked.

“I just put the fucking shirt on Deku”, Katsuki explained with annoyance. “He’s wearing it right now”.

More silence.

“It… Kind of looks like you’re just holding the shirt up in the air”, Sero told him.

“The fuck are you talking about? He’s *wearing* it!”

“I’m wearing it!”, Izuku exclaimed, sounding way too excited. “It’s Kacchan’s shirt!”

“Come on, Deku, wave those shitty arms around!”, Katsuki instructed, poking at the boy’s shoulder. Izuku did as he was told and lifted his arms again, waving them around. Katsuki stared at his friends with expectation.

They all still had that blank look on their faces, as if all they could see was Katsuki holding a shirt up at them.

“Fine”, Katsuki grunted, angry, letting go of the shirt. Now that there was no longer physical contact with Katsuki, the shirt phased right through Izuku and toppled to the floor. “Let’s fucking try again”.

He grabbed another shirt and put it on Izuku. He held one hand to Izuku’s shoulder, which was covered by the shirt, and one hand to the boy’s arm.

“It still looks like you’re holding the shirt up”, Kirishima pointed out, squinting his eyes and leaning forward, as if he was truly putting effort into seeing.

“What the *fuck*?”, Katsuki protested, angry. He grabbed Kirishima’s hand and placed it on Deku’s chest, as if he wanted his friend to feel it. She shirt immediately toppled to the floor as soon as Kirishima touched it, phasing through Deku. “This quirk fucking sucks, man”, Katsuki complained under his breath.

“You should try a hat, Kacchan. Then you can just hold the tip and it will float”, Izuku suggested, eyes drooped and face flushed. Katsuki had successfully gotten the nerd drunk after five beer bottles, even though he, himself, was only feeling a bit tipsy. Or was he drunk? He felt just like himself, and he wasn’t confused or forgetful, so… Maybe he was just better

at hiding his intoxication than Deku, who was sitting cross-legged on the floor and staring up at Katsuki like a lovesick puppy.

“You know what, Deku? That’s actually a good idea”, Katsuki frowned in acknowledgement, running his eyes across the room in search for a hat or something alike it.

“That’s gotta be the first time I’ve ever heard him say that”, Sero’s eyes widened in sincere shock as he whispered to Mina.

“Shut up, asshole. Does anyone have a fucking hat?”, he addressed the whole room, still looking around.

“I could make one”, Yaomomo offered promptly, stepping forward and looking immensely interested in the current interaction with Izuku’s soul. In the blink of an eye, she produced a hat off her belly with no effort, handing it over to Katsuki.

Katsuki placed the hat on the top of Deku’s head and only touched the tip of his finger to the edge of the material. The hat still toppled to the floor as if Izuku was made of nothing but thin air.

“*Fuck*!! Why isn’t this shit working?!”, he exploded, furious.

“Maybe put like… a finger… like a finger on the hat and then you touch me and then the hat will stay in place ‘cause you gotta touch me and the hat… at the same time…”, Izuku mumbled, slurring drunkenly. There was a smile constantly etched on his face, now, and he chuckled a bit once he finished talking, as if he found his own suggestion hilarious.

“*Fine*”, Katsuki said grumpily, bending over and grabbing the hat from the floor. He placed it on Deku’s head again, keeping one hand on the boy’s shoulder and one finger at the hem of the hat.

It phased through Izuku again.

“You got any other goddamn genius idea?”, Katsuki huffed, annoyed at his public failure. He had a hunch that his attempts at making Izuku tangible weren’t working either because: 1. there were people watching; or 2. they were too intoxicated to do it properly. Either way, he had been humiliated enough for one night. Everyone was still staring at them. Izuku hummed low on his throat, eyes drooping closed and toppling to the side. “Oi! Don’t fucking fall asleep on me!”, Katsuki poked him harshly, ignoring all the eyes glued on him.

“Huh? Oh, right… Uh…”, Izuku looked around with glassy eyes, staring at all his friends, then at the hat on the floor. “I… don’t know…?”, he squinted up at Katsuki with an apology written in his eyes.

“Well, fucking great”, Katsuki shook his head and threw his hands in the air. “All right, show’s over, assholes. I can’t fucking make Deku tangible and he’s too drunk to think, so go on about your businesses”.

“Wait… He’s drunk? How is he drunk?”, Kirishima frowned.

“It’s because he’s a fucking lightweight who can’t keep up the same pace as me”, Katsuki smirked proudly, grabbing Izuku by the forearm and pulling him to his feet abruptly. The boy lost balance and ended up leaning heavily on Katsuki, who passed one of Izuku’s arms around his shoulder to support him better. Izuku giggled happily at this, burying his face on Katsuki’s neck.

“Thanks, Kacchan. You heavy”, he chuckled.

“*You’re* heavy”, Katsuki retorted in a quiet voice. For some reason, Deku found that hilarious and started giggling again, his breath making Katsuki’s neck tingle.

“Uh, but how does that make sense?”, Sero asked. “I mean, you both have the same quantity of alcohol inside of you, right? So shouldn’t you be the same level of drunkenness?”

“No one should be drunk in the first place!”, Iida yelled from somewhere in the distance.

“People handle their boozes differently, dumbface”, Katsuki walked past Sero, dragging a giggling Deku along with him. “He’s a lightweight, I’m not. Which is why I’m fucking ok and he’s shitfaced already”.

“’M not”, Izuku protested, giggling and basically being dragged around by Katsuki, who was holding his arm above his shoulders and had his other hand on Izuku’s waist. “Swear ‘m not. ‘M just happy”.

“Of course you fucking are”, Katsuki snorted.

“Told ya you wouldn’t ge’ me poopfaced”. And then he started giggling again at his own joke.

“I fucking hate you so much. If you ever say ‘poopfaced’ near me ever again I’m fucking gonna –“

“You sure you ok, though, bro?”, Mina smiled hesitantly at him, unaware of anything Izuku was saying. “You looking a bit tipsy over there”.

“*Shut up, Raccoon!*”, Katsuki shouted, snarling at the girl. “I ain’t fucking tipsy! I’m just having to carry Deku around because he’s a fucking loser!”

“’M not! I’m cool!”, Izuku protested.

“You guys, we should just keep playing truth and dare!”, Kendo suggested cheerfully from behind them.

“Count me out…”, Uraraka groaned miserably, doing her best to hide her face.

“Wait, I have an idea!”, Izuku exclaimed suddenly, straightening himself out of nowhere and perking up in Katsuki’s grasp. “You could – You could darg – uh, drag, drag me around!”

“And what the fuck is that gonna prove?”, Katsuki frowned at him as if he was stupid.

“Oh, no, wait, I mean, I can drag *you* around!”, he corrected himself. “Sorry, I confused us. It’s confusing. I can drag you around!”

“Like *hell* I’m letting that happen”, Katsuki scoffed, but, completely ignoring him, Izuku released himself from his grasp and stumbled forwards before regaining his footing. Then, before Katsuki could react, he threw himself onto him again. “Oi. *Oi*. The fuck are you doing, asshole?”, Katsuki asked, annoyed, pushing Izuku slightly back. That was enough to catch everyone else’s attentions again.

“I’m gonna hold you up!”, Izuku exclaimed, grabbing Katsuki all over as if he wasn’t sure how he should hold him in order to lift him up.

“Deku. Get the fuck off me”, Katsuki warned through gritted teeth, but Izuku didn’t pay him any mind. Everyone was staring.

“You were trying to interact with me to prove I’m here, bu’ I think it’s easier if *I* interact with *you*”, Izuku explained drunkenly. He crouched over and attempted to pick Katsuki up bridal style, but before he could, Katsuki shoved him away.

“Stop this shit right now! There’s no way in hell I’m letting you pick me up!”, he protested.

“Come on, Kacchan! Pretty pretty pretty pretty *pleeeease*”, Izuku moaned, losing balance and leaning heavily on Katsuki’s front again. He giggled.

“Deku, if you don’t get a grip of your fucking self, I’m gonna knock you the fuck out”, Katsuki threatened. “It’s easier to drag your ass around than to deal with you like this. I should have fucking figured out you’re the annoying-drunk type”.

“I’m no’ annoying. I’m super cool”, Izuku giggled, burying his face on Katsuki’s chest. “And you’re the one who go’ me drunkey”.

“Yeah, because I didn’t think your assholery would be increased by a tenfold. And you’re not fucking cool”.

“All Might thinks I’m cool”.

“What does All Might even know?”

“Uhhh…? Everything, Kacchan? Kacchan. Kacchan. Kacchakacchakaccha. I really love your name”.

“God, shut the fuck up. No more fucking drinks for you, you damn lightweight”, Katsuki scowled.

“No more drinks for you, too, then”, Izuku said in a sing-song voice, words muffled by Katsuki’s shirt. The only thing preventing Izuku from falling face-first on the floor was Katsuki’s upper torso and his hands around the boy’s waist.

“Uh… Everything alright there, man?”, Kirishima asked. The rest of the group had gradually dispersed, even though there were still too many people staring at them.

“Fucking fine”, Katsuki gritted out. “Go play your dumb games or whatever”.

“I wanna play truth or dare!”, Izuku said, raising his head. He leaned more of his weight on Katsuki, who had to set a foot back in order not to lose balance.

“You don’t get to want anything after this scene you’re pulling”, Katsuki scolded him. “Stop being a baby and get a grip of your fucking self. God, I’m a fucking moron for thinking this would be a good idea”.

“Hmph”, was Izuku’s only groaned response as he buried his face on Katsuki’s chest again.

Way too much physical contact, especially after the days of deprivation. However, Katsuki was too out of it to put any mind into that at the moment. All he could focus on was Deku’s weight and Deku’s warm breath, which were making his skin buzz as if with electricity.

“Come along, then!”, Kirishima said, deaf and blind to Izuku’s antics. “We’re getting back to truth or dare!”

“Do I fucking have to?”, Katsuki sighed grumpily. Kirishima turned to look at him, studying his face for a moment before shrugging.

“Only if you want to, man”, he said.

From the expression on his face, Katsuki could tell that Kirishima fucking wanted him to tag along, but respected him enough not to force him into it. Without waiting for a response, Kirishima walked away and joined the newly formed circle on the floor. This time, there were more people participating, but Uraraka and Jirou had decided to stay out of it, just watching the game from the outside instead. Iida had decided to stay out as well, meaning to keep his friend company (and because he hadn’t really gotten the hang of the game). Katsuki had just noticed Icy Hot was missing from the circle as well when a firm hand grabbed his shoulder.

He turned on his heels, still holding most of the half-awake Deku’s weight up, only to see Icy Hot staring down at him with the most presumptuous look ever. Just staring at Todoroki’s face was enough to rot Katsuki’s mood down completely, and any trace of humor or relaxation immediately disappeared from his face when their eyes met.

“The fuck you want?”, he asked the boy in front of him, sounding snappy and impatient for no reason. Deku was too out of it to pay total attention to the interaction, one of his arms hanging from the top of Katsuki’s shoulders as he was supported up by the boy.

“You got Midoriya *drunk*?”, Todoroki asked, sounding like he was trying very hard not to jump at Katsuki right then and there. For some reason, the thought that the bastard was fucking questioning him made it hard for Katsuki to control his temper.

“Yeah, and what the fuck is it to you?”, Katsuki spat, furious. His answer seemed to infuriate Todoroki even further, because suddenly there was danger written all over his multicolored eyes as he took a step closer to Katsuki.

“In the state his body is in, you shouldn’t be straining it even further”, he reprimanded, sounding like an overprotective parent. “Especially if what you said All Might told you is true”. Katsuki scoffed and scowled at him.

“You saying I’m lying about All Might?”, Katsuki snorted with disdain. “You think I’d go through all that trouble just because of a lame asshole as you?”

“I don’t know, you tell me”, Todoroki defied.

“What, you think I didn’t think this through, asshole? You think I’m one of your dumb fucking friends?”, he scoffed. “Deku’s damn body isn’t affected in the same way his soul is”.

“And you know that how?”

“Because I broke the fucker’s nose and his body was just fine”, he said without really thinking about it (thanks, alcohol). Todoroki’s eyes widened and, in a moment, he was glaring down at Katsuki, looking like he was about to unwillingly activate his left side.

“You broke Midoriya’s *nose*?”

And yeah, ok, Katsuki had to admit that from the way he said it, he could understand Todoroki getting angry. But also, how the fuck could he explain that he hadn’t meant to punch Deku this time and that it had been an accident? How could he say that he had touched the scar on Deku’s back and freaked out because he suddenly remembered everything that had happened during the villain fight?

“It’s none of your damn business”, Katsuki spat instead of justifying himself, because that was better than sounding weak, especially in front of Icy Hot. He knew what the bastard must have been thinking, and he knew what his words had sounded like. But, for what must have been the first time ever, he hadn’t actually meant to hurt Deku when he broke his nose. He truly hadn’t.

“It’s my business if you’re hurting my friend”, Todoroki argued, his voice dangerously low. They were starting to catch some eyes, Uraraka’s and Iida’s mostly, but most of the students at the party were too busy with the recently started game of truth or dare to pay attention to the tension growing on the other side of the room.

“I ain’t fucking hurting him”, Katsuki took a step towards Todoroki, anger and annoyance carved into his expression in an animalistic way. Izuku lifted his head, his glassy eyes struggling to focus on Todoroki in front of them.

“Todoroki-kun”, he smiled affectionately and drunkenly after a few moments of blurry recognition, releasing himself from Katsuki’s grasp and throwing himself on Todoroki as if he wanted to hug him. Katsuki held him back before he could do that, not just because he knew Deku would phase through Todoroki and fall on his face as a result, but also because… Well. *Other reasons*.

“I’m actually doing more to fucking help him than you are”, Katsuki accused, ignoring the way Deku squirmed as he pulled him closer to himself and continuing to glare at Todoroki.

“Oh, yes? Is that why you ignored my plan to figure out what’s going on with Midoriya and chose to stay safely in your comfort zone instead of actually doing something *heroic* for once?”

Katsuki’s nostrils flared and his hold on Deku tightened. Deku frowned.

“No”, he growled. “That’s why I fucking found a *better way* to figure out what’s going on with Deku’s body, instead of risking my fucking career because of a reckless fucking plan”, he spat. “Not all of us have a famous *daddy* who can buy our asses out of trouble whenever we do something fucking illegal”.

It was Todoroki’s time to flare his nostrils. More eyes in the room fixed on them.

“I don’t know what is going on with you, Bakugou”, Todoroki said as stoically as ever. If it hadn’t been for the silent fury in his eyes, he would have looked just as bored and disinterested as he ever did. “But if you hurt Midoriya –“

“You’re gonna do *what*?”, Katsuki interrupted him, anger taking over every fiber of his being. He could feel some of it seeping into shitty Deku as a result, as a way to level it out – which was something that hadn’t happened in days.

Silence. In fact, the whole room had gone silent, now. Everyone was watching the discussion.

“I’m going to make sure you pay for it. Midoriya has put up with your abuse for long enough”.

Katsuki scoffed, smirked, and glared at Todoroki, all at the same time. This fucker thought he knew anything about his relationship with Deku? He thought he *knew* Deku better than him?

“Oh, yeah? And how are you gonna do *that*, Icy Hot?”

Todoroki’s hands tightened into fists, his face neutral, his eyes furious.

“You look like you would like me to give you a demonstration”.

That was Katsuki’s breaking point.

“Oh, bring it the *fuck* on”, he said.

“Kacchan”, Izuku groaned, trying to stand between Katsuki and Todoroki. “Don’…”, he repeated, as if he couldn’t form anything more coherent than that.

“Get out of the way, Deku”, Katsuki said through gritted teeth, voice guttural and angry. Izuku continued to place himself in front of him, clinging desperately to the front of Katsuki’s shirt and struggling to regain his footing on his own.

“Midoriya, step aside”, Todoroki said, as if he could see Deku, as if he had *any fucking right* to address him. It pissed Katsuki off to no end.

“Don’t you fucking *talk* to him, asshole!”, he screamed, explosions popping in his hands.

“Why? Why should you be the only one to talk to him?”, Todoroki inquired, bracing himself to fight as well. Izuku meekly attempted to push Katsuki away, but stumbled.

“Because I’m the one who can see him, you stupid piece of shit!”

“*And* the one who can break his nose for no reason, apparently”, Todoroki accused. A series of shocked murmurs erupted in the room, and Katsuki could feel disapproval in the eyes that were glued to him.

“I’ll fucking *kill* you!”, he jumped at Todoroki.

“Bakugou!”

“Hey, wait!”

“Bakugou-kun!”

“Oh my god!”

“Kacchan, no!”

“Ok, that’s enough, guys!”, Kirishima said, throwing himself between the two boys with his hardening quirk activated. Both his arms were stretched out, hands touching both Katsuki’s and Todoroki’s chest in order to push them away from each other. Izuku was leaning heavily on Katsuki, looking worried. He had placed himself in a position that made it look like he was trying to use himself as a human shield to protect Katsuki from Todoroki’s attack. Kirishima’s hand had phased right through him as he held a fuming Katsuki back, but Kirishima couldn’t know that and Izuku didn’t seem to have noticed it. “Seriously? You’re going to do this on my damn birthday?”, Kirishima asked, dismayed.

“Get out of the way, Kirishima”, Katsuki growled, even though he made no effort to walk past his best friend. “This asshole wants a fight with me? I’m gonna give him one”.

“Katsuki, *stop*!”, Kirishima exclaimed, and ok, that was a first.

There was a hurt look in Kirishima’s eyes as he stared at his best friend, and the fact that he had just used Katsuki’s first name indicated that he was extremely serious – in fact, more serious than ever. Katsuki stopped trying to move forwards, but his hands were still tightened into fists and he was still snarling at Todoroki from the top of Kirishima’s shoulder.

“I’m serious, man!”, Kirishima added after Katsuki stood down but didn’t relax. “The last thing I want today is for my friends to fight! Can you two respect me, just a little? Just this once?”, he turned to look at Todoroki as well, still holding them both back.

“Kacchan”, Izuku groaned, leaning heavily on him. “’M dizzy”.

“Just stop, the two of you!”, Kirishima continued, lowering his arms but still standing between them. “I know you both care about Midoriya, but you don’t have to fight each other over him”.

“What the *fuck*, Shitty –“

“I’m serious, man, *stand down*!”, Kirishima snapped at him for what was probably the first time ever. Katsuki stared at him. “We’re here to celebrate and have fun, not have a damn fight. I thought you were my friend”, he accused, hurt evident in his eyes.

Katsuki continued to stare at him. Kirishima looked very upset.

“I *am* your friend”, Katsuki said angrily, as if he couldn’t believe Kirishima would dare to doubt that. He didn’t have the time, or the mind, to think about how that was the first time he had ever said it out loud – his brain was too muddled by beer, anger, and worry.

“Then let this one *go*!”, Kirishima said, distraught. “You too, Todoroki!”, he turned to look at the other boy. “After everything he’s been going through, Midoriya deserves to have some drinks and a bit of fun!”

Todoroki looked like he wanted to argue, like he wanted to finish what he had started, but in respect for Kirishima, he stood back, relaxing.

“Fine by me”, Todoroki raised both hands in surrender, his face still as stoic as ever. “But if Bakugou hurts Midoriya again…”

“I didn’t fucking do it on *purpose*”, Katsuki spat through gritted teeth, even though he hated himself for feeling the need to give Icy Hot an explanation. Todoroki simply glared at him, disbelief evident in his eyes.

“Just let it go. Ok? Stop this”, Kirishima insisted, eyes fixed on Katsuki. Katsuki stared at him, looking like he still wanted retaliation, but he eventually sighed and nodded briefly. Kirishima relaxed, lowering his arms and deactivating his quirk.

“*Damn*, you guys. Can we just have one day of confraternization without someone picking a fight?”, Mina said from where she was still sitting on the truth or dare circle.

“I’m with Mina”, Yaomomo nodded. “We’re training to be pro heroes. It’s not right to have such a childish behavior”.

“Yeah. Let’s all just chill, all right?”, Sero suggested.

“And stop drinking for the night!”, Iida added assertively.

Kirishima noticed Katsuki’s hands tightening back into fists at the sudden commentary and grabbed his wrist before he could say – or explode – anything, giving his best friend a serious, meaningful look.

“I mean it, man. Just stand down”, he asked in a low voice so that only Katsuki could hear him, a serious look on his face.

“*Fine*”, Katsuki grunted, yanking his hand away from Kirishima’s hold and glaring at the carpet.

“Ok. Can we all agree to call it a truce?”, Kirishima announced loudly, eyes darting between Katsuki and Todoroki. Todoroki nodded and looked away, whereas Katsuki stayed silent, offering no acceptance but no denial, either. “Right. Ok, let’s get back to the game, then!”, Kirishima announced cheerfully, even though it felt a bit forced, like he was still upset. He walked back towards the circle, but when Katsuki didn’t follow, he stopped on his tracks. “Come on, man. You’re playing with us”, he gestured for Katsuki to follow.

“You said I only had to play if I fucking wanted to”, Katsuki pointed out grumpily, still glaring at the floor and ignoring Deku’s weight leaning on him.

“That was *before* you almost blew up half the party”, Kirishima said in a tone that didn’t leave place for a discussion, sitting on the floor and opening up some space for Katsuki and Izuku right beside him. “Now you gotta play as a proper apology. Come on! It’s going to be fun. You too, Todoroki!”, he gestured at the boy, who was standing farther away than Katsuki.

Katsuki rolled his eyes so hard he almost managed to see his own brain. Izuku tugged at his shirt quietly, staring up at him with droopy eyes.

“I’d like to play”, he said, smiling softly at Katsuki. “And have some fuuuuun”.

“*Fine*”, Katsuki sighed, rolling his eyes again and walking towards the circle. The answer was for both Kirishima and Izuku.

“Yaaay!”, the drunk Izuku exclaimed cheerfully.

Katsuki figured he would better start drinking some water in order to detox himself before Izuku was too far gone.

“Kiri, truth or dare?”

“Dare!”

“I dare you to… Impersonate Bakugou!”

A series of laughter.

“Hey! Shitty Hair! Don’t fucking look at my general direction! Die! Die! Die! You! Die! *Dekuuuuuuu*!”, Kirishima impersonated accurately, making his voice more guttural. More laughter erupted from the group, whereas Katsuki simply fumed, snarling.

“I sound nothing like that, you piece of shit!”

“*I sound nothing like that, you piece of shit!*”, Kirishima immediately imitated, sounding almost exactly like his best friend. More laughter.

“He’s good”, Izuku chuckled.

“Shut up”, Katsuki spat with annoyance.

“Fine, let’s spin it again”, Kirishima leaned forwards, still smiling, and spun the bottle. It pointed to Hagakure and Tsuyu.

“Hagakure-chan, do you want truth or dare?”, Tsuyu asked.

“Truth!”, Hagakure exclaimed cheerfully. Tsuyu took a pensive finger to her chin before elaborating a question.

“Do you know what you look like?”

Everyone stared at Hagakure, who pondered about the question for a moment.

“I mean… I know what I used to look like before my quirk manifested! I wasn’t born invisible, you know… But after that, I only tried it once… I asked a friend to throw paint on my face so that I could look at myself in the mirror! I think I looked pretty good!”

“We should try it sometime!”, Uraraka exclaimed from where she was watching the game outside the circle. “See what Hagakure-san looks like!”

“I agree!”, Mina exclaimed cheerfully. “Does anyone have paint here?”

“I’m in for it!”, Hagakure exclaimed, sounding excited. “It’s pretty tiring to be invisible all the time!”

“Tell me about it”, Izuku muttered from where he was leaning his head on Katsuki’s shoulder. Katsuki snorted out a laugh.

Both of them were too out of it to care about the physical contact – Izuku, because he was way too drunk, and Katsuki because he was slightly drunk. Either way, they were both comfortable touching each other, and being close to each other – not only because they had already done those things a few days before, but because they were both intoxicated and Deku could no longer sit up straight, so it wasn’t like he had any other choice but to lean on Katsuki. Icy Hot kept sending Katsuki side looks from where he was sitting directly in front of him, but, for Kirishima’s sake, Katsuki ignored him.

The amount of physical contact wasn’t really bothering him, if he had to be honest.

“My time to spin!”, Hagakure announced, spinning the bottle. It pointed at Yaomomo and Deku.

“Uhh…. Yaoyorozu-san… Do you wan’ truth or…? What’s the other one?”, he frowned up at Katsuki, who rolled his eyes.

“He’s asking truth or dare”, he announced in a deadpan, looking bored.

“I think I’m going with truth!”, Yaomomo announced.

“What’s the largest thing you’ve ever created with your quirk?”

“Really? *That’s* the question you’re going with?”

“You’ve got a better idea, Kacchan?”

“Uh, *yeah*, asshole. Several”.

“Bakugou, we can only hear your side of the argument!”, Sero protested. “Just tell us what Midoriya’s asking!”

“He wants to know what’s the largest thing you’ve ever created with your quirk”, Katsuki sighed.

“Oh”, Yaomomo blinked in surprise, as if she hadn’t been expecting a quirk-related question. Given the previous questions that had been going around in that truth or dare game, she wasn’t wrong to be surprised. “Well, I believe… I believe it was a cannon…”, she said pensively.

“Really? How big was it? How long did it take to get ready? Were you too tired out afterwards? What –“

“Deku, you only get to ask one fucking question”, Katsuki interrupted the rambling.

“Oh, right, sorry”, Izuku said, embarrassed.

“Am I the one who spins it, now?”, Yaomomo asked Mina, who nodded at her. “All right”, she said, leaning forwards and spinning the bottle. It pointed to Katsuki and Mina.

“Truth or dare, Bakubro?”, Mina asked, sounding way more excited than she should be. Immediately knowing she was up to something, Katsuki knew he would end up getting wrecked if he chose truth.

“Dare”, he said triumphantly, challenge evident in his eyes.

“I dare you to give Kiri a peck on the cheek!”

“What?!”

“Ooooh!”

“Mina, you’re asking for it, aren’t you!”

“Rest in peace, Mina-chan”.

“That’s not allowed, is it?”

“Like fucking *hell* I will!”, Katsuki grunted out.

“It’s a dare, Bakugou! You can’t turn out from a dare!”, Mina pointed out. “Consider it a birthday gift!”

“I already got him a birthday gift!”, Katsuki growled. Izuku was very quiet beside him.

“*Which* he hasn’t opened yet!”, Sero pointed out.

“That’s hardly my fucking business, is it?”

“Bakugou, it’s ok, man”, Kirishima chuckled, raising his hands in a calming gesture and looking like he was trying to promote peace among the group. “You don’t have to do it, it’s fine”.

“You *don’t* have to do it”, Mina shrugged dismissively. “But if you don’t, you’re a chicken”.

“Do you have a *deathwish*?!”, Sero exclaimed, giving Mina a horrified look.

“Bakubro could never hurt me!”, Mina blew Bakugou a kiss.

“Try your luck, Raccoon Eyes”, Katsuki growled animalistically.

“Mina can choose some other dare!”, Kirishima tried to offer.

“Oh, Mina can choose a *lot* of other dares”, Mina smirked evilly. Kirishima eyed her with a pleading look, aware that Katsuki wasn’t in a mood to be played with. “If he didn’t want to be challenged, he should have picked truth instead”, she added, unrelenting. “Now, he either does my dare or he’s a”, she mimicked a chicken using her arms. “Coward!”

“Oh, I’ll fucking show you who the fucking coward is”, Katsuki snarled, surging forwards but being held back by Kirishima’s hand on his chest.

“It’s just a peck on the cheek! It’s no biggie!”, Mina provided.

“Mina, *stop teasing* him”, Kirishima pleaded, still holding Katsuki back.

“Never! Bakugou is the coolest to tease!”, she chuckled, and only then Katsuki noticed she was a bit intoxicated as well. That explained why she seemed to have lost her fucking sense of self-preservation.

“You suck at dares, Raccoon Eyes”, Katsuki growled, slowly nudging Deku away so that he could turn to Kirishima, who was sitting right beside him and still holding a hand to his chest. “You’d better hope not to catch me on a next round, because I’ll fuck you up no matter what you choose”.

“Bakugou, really, you don’t have to –“, Kirishima tried to say as Katsuki approached him, but was interrupted by the boy dropping a quick, barely feelable kiss on his cheek. He blushed,

and Katsuki simply sat back down as if that had been no big deal. Most of the members of the circle failed to see the peck, since it had been so quick, but Mina, who had been watching closely and with sharp attention, widened her eyes in surprise and shock.

“Oh my god, he actually did it!”, she exclaimed.

“I told you I ain’t no fucking coward, you dumbass!”, Katsuki shouted.

“That was the manliest kiss… Anyone has ever given me…”, Kirishima said in a heartfelt way.

“Ah, shut the fuck up”, Katsuki rolled his eyes.

Instead of leaning his head on his shoulder again, like he had been doing before Katsuki moved, Izuku decided to stay sitting upright. Katsuki spared him a single questioning look, but when the boy didn’t meet his eyes, a blank expression on his face, he decided to ignore him. Deku was probably just feeling the effect of the alcohol or some shit like that.

“Fine. I’m the one who has to spin this shit, now?”, he asked before spinning the bottle. It ended up pointing to Sero and Tetsutetsu, which resulted on an arm wrestle that lasted longer than anyone had expected.

The game went on for a while, and Izuku sat silently beside Katsuki for a long time, not saying anything. The quick, excited comments he’d been delivering early into the game no longer happened. The bottle didn’t point to him anymore, but it did point at Katsuki a couple times again, but only for him to ask people truth or dare, and not to choose. Much to Mina’s luck, Katsuki didn’t get in another round with her again.

Eventually, everyone had chosen both truth and dare at least once, and once the game got too repetitive, they decided to play Uno instead. It was only when Kirishima asked Izuku if he would want to play too that Katsuki realized the boy had fallen asleep, god knows how long ago, his chin uncomfortably glued to his chest as a thin streak of saliva fell off the corner of his mouth. His position was stiff and he looked about to topple to the side, which made Katsuki roll his eyes. Why hadn’t the nerd just leaned his head on his shoulder like he had been doing before?

“He doesn’t want to play”, Katsuki told Kirishima, who had been waiting for a response and who didn’t know that Izuku was asleep. Kirishima sorted out the cards and handed the decks to everyone who wanted to play.

Katsuki waited until no one was looking at him so that he could drag himself a bit, just a tiny bit closer to Deku, and nudge his head onto his shoulder once more, so that the boy would get to sleep more comfortably – or as comfortably as he possibly could, in that situation.

I just don’t want his neck to be sore, otherwise my neck will be sore, too, Katsuki told himself, trying his best not to feel angry or pathetic for helping the sleeping Deku out.

Except he was drunk, and who the fuck was he kidding? He had started caring about Deku somewhere along the way, and he didn’t want the boy’s neck to be sore. Period. And Deku

might still annoy the fuck out of him, but he also made… He made Katsuki feel stuff that he didn't know he could feel before. That he didn't know how to deal with.

Deku sighed as he rested on his shoulder. Katsuki's childish, stubborn part tried to convince him that he shouldn't be enjoying Deku's company, or Deku's touches, or Deku's proximity.

Katsuki didn't know what to think about that voice just yet, so he decided he was better off beating his dumbass friends in the fucking Uno until he figured his shit out.

Halfway into the night, most of the students from Class 1-A – and some of the visitors from Class 1-B – were already drunk as hell, even though no one dared to drink anymore after the Bakugou-Todoroki almost-fight.

Deku was sleeping heavily and wouldn't wake up if the world ended right around him, being drunk as he was. Katsuki wasn't totally wasted, but his mind was fuzzy and light just like he liked it to be when he drank with his friends. Still, no matter what his level of intoxication was, he didn't trip on his feet or look drunk at all – to any outside viewer, he looked perfectly sober. That was his damn secret, after all – fake it 'til you make it.

However, no matter how much lighter he felt and how dizzy he was, he couldn't stop thinking about his argument with Icy Hot. And every damn time Katsuki looked at the bastard, the bastard was looking right back at him, as if he was actually watching Katsuki to ensure he wasn't about to fucking murder Deku's soul or some shit.

Katsuki wanted to punch him. He wanted to punch that half-and-half bastard so bad. But, for Kirishima's sake, he didn't. *Not now*.

But who the hell did Icy Hot think he was? Throwing accusations to his face, acting as if he knew any fucking thing about Deku, acting as if Bakugou was still a 15-year-old kid who beat Deku up and mistreated him. Fine, he had been that kid and there was no denying it, but he was also doing infinitely better now! He was *getting* better. He was getting fucking better, and he was being good to Deku! Right? He couldn't change the past, but he could improve the future. And even though Deku was a pain in the ass and practically put an effort into *making* Katsuki lose his patience with him… He was trying to be better. He was taking him to visit his mom, he was letting him sleep on his bed, he was having actual conversations with him, he was… he was…

Yeah, that was pretty much it.

Fuck.

He still had a lot to improve, hadn't he?

But Katsuki would fucking show him. Icy Hot thought he was so much better than him, right? Not using his left on the damn sports festival, staring down at him with that fucking annoying superior tone, acting like he was the Deku Carer Number One. Katsuki would *show him* who was the number one. He would fucking show him.

His legs acted before his brain caught up with his idea and, before he knew better, he was interrupting a conversation between Yaomomo and Jirou. The girls stared up at him with surprise, as if they hadn't expected for someone like Katsuki to talk to them in a party.

But his mind was made up. There were still things he needed to find out, still things he needed to understand. All Might's story only made sense to a certain point, and he knew there was something the school was still hiding from them. It was about damn time they figured out what the fuck was actually going on, and, unfortunately, shitty useless Deku was *sleeping like the dead* on his shoulder (Katsuki was carrying the sleeping boy's soul above his shoulder like a sack of potatoes, since this was the easiest way to carry him without hurting him or Katsuki's own back) and he had resisted all the attempts Katsuki had made to wake him up. Everything he had tried to rouse Deku had resulted on either a sigh and a grunt or on a dreamy "*Kacchan*", which left his alcohol-riddled mind, which was still fucking brilliant, thank you very much, with only one plausible choice.

"Hey, Earphone Girl", Katsuki said, doing his best not to look or sound tipsy – and succeeding. Fuck, he was fucking great at playing sober.

"Is everything alright, Bakugou?", Jirou frowned at him, as did Yaomomo. They weren't used to having Katsuki talk to them for no reason.

"You busy or something?", Katsuki asked, playing it cool as if not to call attention. Jirou blinked blankly at him and her eyes darted between Katsuki and Yaomomo, as if she didn't know what was the right answer to that question.

"Uh… Do you need anything?", she settled for saying at the same time she frowned, confused.

"Actually, yeah", Katsuki nodded. He didn't offer any explanation or requests, simply staring at her and waiting for her to follow him.

"Oh… Ok, then…?", Jirou frowned again, clearly awkward. "Does it have to be right now?"

"You fucking tell me", Katsuki shrugged. Jirou looked at Yaomomo again.

"It's ok", Yaomomo smiled, taking a few steps back. "I can explain the rest for you later!"

"Okay…", Jirou turned back to look at Katsuki, suspicion etched all over her eyes. She waited until Yaomomo was out of ear range to cross her arms above her chest and give Katsuki a half-inquiring, half-concerned look. "What's up?", she asked, raising an eyebrow at him.

“Tag along”, Katsuki nodded at the exit of the common room and walked towards it without looking behind him to see if the girl was following. Jirou hesitated for a moment before letting out a breath and following Katsuki’s tracks, curious as to why he needed *her*, of all people. Everyone was still having so much fun that no one noticed their absence.

“Where are we going?”, she asked once they were in the main hall, away from all the noise and the people. The sudden change in the atmosphere was evident – the empty hall was so deprived of the loud noises of conversation and laughter that had been filling the common room that it made both their ears ring in discord. The only sounds there were the echoes of Katsuki’s footsteps, and of Jirou’s as she followed him closely.

“Just fucking tag along”, Katsuki said simply, not looking at her. “I’ll explain on the way”.

He would show Icy Hot. He would fucking show him.

Chapter End Notes

The writer is extremely aware that a bunch of underages shouldn't be drinking together and that this is not healthy or morally correct, but the writer is also not a hypocrite and is extremely aware that underages still find ways to drink in real life whether it's legal or not, so welp

Look, we're finally getting somewhere! Wonder what Bakugou wants Jirou's help for...

I hope this turned out well! I'm really plus ultra-ing myself over here... In the sense that I'm using every second of my spare time (which isn't much) to write this. I'm aware that updates are taking a long while, but I'm also having to work 9 hours a day + the two hours that take me to get to work and the two hours that take me to get back home. WHAT I MEAN IS I know things are slow right now and sorry if this chapter felt... rushed? Weird? Awkward? OOC? I don't know... I kind of like it, to be honest, but while writing it I couldn't stop worrying if you guys would enjoy it too or if you would think Bakugou drinking is a bit too much. I just love the image of him trying new things and doing his best to seem like a "bad boy", while still doing stuff like getting the best grades and going to sleep at 8 p.m. (we'll never let the poor boy rest over this one, right?). Anyway. Despite of the tiredness, this story sure as fuck was worth writing it, if not for the fun of it, then for the feedback you guys give me! Truly, I just love your comments so much. Thank you for reading through everything I've been writing here so far and for taking the time to tell me nice things! A writer is truly nothing without its readers. And I just love writing this story so much, you know?

Also, I finally figured out how many chapters long this story will be (19). If you follow me on twitter, you might have gotten a glimpse on what I plan the chapter titles to be before I panicked and deleted the tweet after like, ten minutes. Anyway... We still have a longe-ish way ahead of us, but we're also more than halfway through this! Is this sad? Is this good? Are you relieved you won't have to sit through more than twenty 20K-long

chapters? I have no idea! I just hope you guys like reading this story as much as I like writing it!

I believe the next chapter will be posted more quickly than this one... Carnaval is coming up here in Brazil and I'll have three days off, which I'll take to work on this!

Also, something I've been meaning to say for a while is that I'm an absolute slut for foreshadowing, so... Maybe try to find the hints I dropped on the previous chapters and on this one? Or don't, keep yourself unaware of the painful path ahead of us (while you can) ;-)

See ya next time and thanks for reading!

Chapter 13: Fear of Collision

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Their steps echoed soundly on the empty corridors as they marched across them with hurry, almost in perfect synchrony, Izuku's limp head bouncing in accordance with each of Katsuki's heavy steps.

"What's the range of your quirk?", he asked in a deadpan as soon as they began to climb down the stairs, being mindful to slow his pace down in order not to rattle Deku's head too hard.

Jirou, who was a few steps behind Katsuki, stared at him, a sudden frown painting her face. It became clear that this question was not what she had been expecting Katsuki to say.

"Why do you want to know?", was her suspicious response, as if only now she was beginning to wonder about the real reason why Katsuki had snatched her out of the party.

He growled low in his throat in a sign of irritation instead of offering a proper answer, and that didn't seem to please Jirou's sudden wary state, since she stopped on her tracks in the middle of the stairs and stood there, watching him. It took Katsuki a few moments more than it should have for him to realize Jirou was no longer following him and, once he did, he also came to a stop, turning on his heels a few stairs beneath her in order to offer the girl a glare. She didn't look intimidated by the look, though. Just more suspicious.

"Why do you want to know the range of my quirk?", she insisted, still frowning at him. And then, again: "Where are we going?"

Katsuki suppressed the urge to tell her a hundred variations of curse words and snarled.

"I told you I would fucking explain it on the way", Katsuki spat, annoyed at the sudden halt. He didn't want to take longer than necessary to do what needed to be done, or to stay out too long. He may want to shove his superiority on Icy Hot's face, but he wouldn't be able to do so if he got caught breaking curfew.

"We're already on the way", Jirou pointed out, crossing her arms above her chest and tilting her head slightly to the side in curiosity. "I thought you just needed my help to blast some music for the party, but that's not it, is it?", her lazy eyes squinted at him. Katsuki huffed a heavy breath out through his nose and looked away from her, shaking his head in annoyance and disapproval before glaring at the girl again. His face was a mixture of angry and displeased, but, at the same time, he looked as if he was trying his best not to blow her and half the dorm building up.

"Why the fuck would we *blast some music at the party* if it's a fucking school night and we don't want to get caught getting shitfaced up there?", he pointed out in return, adjusting Deku, who was beginning to slip off his shoulder, against him. Jirou blushed and looked

away for a moment, seeming embarrassed by Katsuki's reasonable observation, and tightening her arms around her own torso. After a few seconds, she met his eyes again, determination, however shy, etched in her eyes.

"I want to know where we are going, and what for", she said, firm, even if her cheeks were still tinged slightly pink. "Or else I'm not going with you".

Katsuki scoffed at her, adjusting Izuku on his shoulder again. All the wriggling the boy was doing in his drunken sleep wasn't making it easier for Katsuki to carry him, and he poked one of the boy's ribs in an attempt to make him settle down, as if he was a rebel puppy.

"The fuck do you even care where we're going?", Katsuki said, annoyed. Was it really that fucking hard for her just to take a leap of faith and trust his better judgement?

"Uh", Jirou scoffed, sounding almost offended, "you just snatched me out of your best friend's party without telling me why or what for, and now you're apparently leading me *out* of the dorm in the middle of a school night *after* curfew", she said as if it was obvious. "You said you'd explain it on the way, but I'm still waiting for it. I'm not about to get myself into trouble – or – or, wander around in the dark with a guy who barely bothers remembering my name", she added meaningfully. Her blush seemed to increase at these last words, but she stood her ground, unfaltering in her conviction to get an explanation out of Katsuki.

Katsuki squinted at her, angry. He knew that she was right to demand an explanation, especially since they barely even talked to each other and could hardly be considered anything other than colleagues, but things would be way fucking easier if she just tagged along without asking any questions or making any demands.

But since when did Katsuki like to have things easy, anyway?

"*Fine*", he said, adjusting the slipping, sleeping Izuku on his shoulder once again. Fuck, the nerd was heavy *and* fidgety. Maybe Katsuki should just drop his ass on the floor and trust their soulbond to do the job of dragging him along. "We're going to All Might's room", he added matter-of-factly, before turning on his heels and continuing his march down the stairs as if that information was all she needed to know.

It took Jirou a few seconds to catch up with what she had just been told and, once she finally made sense of the words 'we're going to All Might's room', she blinked blankly at Katsuki's moving form and promptly chased after him.

"What did you say? All Might's *room*?", she asked, catching up with Katsuki and staring up at his impassive face as he continued to march forwards, ignoring her. "What do you want to do at All Might's room in the middle of the night?"

"We're not going *into* his room", was Katsuki's indifferent response as he continued walking. "Which is why I want to know what's the range of your damn quirk".

Jirou stopped in her tracks once again, but, when Katsuki continued walking without her, she increased her pace and stopped in front of him, making him come to a stop while a somber look took over her face.

“This is about Midoriya, isn’t it?”, she asked, serious, her eyes telling Katsuki that she already knew the answer to her own question. He didn’t have time to play any games with her, though.

“I don’t know, Ears, what the fuck do you think this is about?”, he snapped, annoyed. He tried to walk past her, but she blocked his way once again, her hand firm against his chest and pushing him slightly back.

“Porcupine…”, Izuku mumbled in his sleep, trying to grab a handful of Katsuki’s spiky hair but failing, since his limbs were too heavy for him. Katsuki rolled his eyes and batted the boy’s hand away (not as hard as he could have).

“Todoroki asked me for the same thing”, Jirou told Katsuki, and his crimson eyes sharpened at the statement.

So Icy Hot had the same fucking idea as him, right? Hah. The bastard probably thought he was *ahead* of him. Most likely after he realized Katsuki wasn’t about to let ghost Deku meddle in his damn shitty plan. And yeah, ok, he had to admit that things would be considerably easier if he *could* use Deku to spy on All Might like Icy Hot had suggested, but the nerd was fucking shitfaced and dead to the world on his shoulder, and Katsuki didn’t want to wait any fucking longer.

Icy Hot loved to act like he was better than him, like he was superior with that stoic shitty face of his and that stuck up tone – he even thought he would have been able to defeat Katsuki without using his full power. But Katsuki would fucking show him. And he would fucking show him in front of *everyone*.

But, for him to do that, he needed Earphone Girl. He wasn’t about to get his ass busted because he tried to eavesdrop on All Might alone – that would only humiliate him further. And this whole shit would be a waste of time if he didn’t find out what was the range of the girl’s damn hearing quirk.

“I told him I wouldn’t help him”, Jirou added, breaking him away from his thoughts, and Katsuki squinted at her. *What*?

“What the fuck?”, he scowled, frowning. Jirou seemed untroubled by the display of indignation.

“I won’t help you, either. It’s too dangerous”, she continued, shaking her head slightly. “You’re not dumb, so you know I’m right”.

Without waiting for a reaction or a response, Jirou let go of him and walked away, headed to the stairs and back to the party. Katsuki glared at her.

“Oi”, he called after her.

Jirou didn’t turn to look.

"*Oi*", he called again, chasing after her and grabbing her by the wrist while trying to balance the sleeping Deku on his shoulder with his other hand. "Don't *fucking* walk away from me".

Jirou snatched her arm away from Katsuki's grasp, glaring at him. Katsuki snarled at her in return.

"Look", he continued, as patiently as he possibly could (which wasn't much, since his teeth were gritted and there was a vein popping in his temple). He was aware that he had to keep his anger at bay if he had any chance at convincing her. He was getting better at controlling his rage, right? He'd been training that for days, now. This was his first real test, especially since Deku was too unconscious to balance his feelings out should he erupt in an angry fit. This was all up to *him*. "I don't know what it was that Half'n'Half bastard told you, but my plan is different. We won't get caught".

"You can't know that", Jirou interrupted him, clearly wary. "And I'm sorry, Bakugou, but I'm not risking getting expelled over you".

She started to climb the stairs again, not looking back. Katsuki watched her go for a few moments before shaking his head in increasing anger. He would be fucking damned if he stoop so low as to beg for her help. He would rather die before begging anyone for anything.

He was Katsuki fucking Bakugou. He would find a way to do this shit by himself, without needing any extra to help him.

"Fucking *fine*, then", he snarled and scoffed. "See if I need your fucking help".

Jirou didn't stop, disappearing from view as she turned on the corner. Katsuki scoffed angrily again, adjusting Izuku on his shoulder for what was probably the hundredth time.

"Some great fucking hero you are", he muttered under his breath, turning on his heels and heading for the door. *If you want it done, do it yourself*.

It was stupid of him to even fucking rely on another person's help in the first damn place. That was probably Deku's shitty influence doing things to his brain. He was better off alone – he had always been and he would always be. Counting on other people and needing other people's help only ever did more harm than good, anyway. There was only one fucking person he knew he could always count on, and that was himself.

"What did you say?", he heard Jirou ask from the distance, sounding almost a mixture of offended and indignant, just as he was about to walk out of the dorm building. He glared at her over his shoulder, one hand still holding the door open.

"I said you're some great fucking hero", Katsuki answered without missing a beat, because he could be many things, but he wasn't a damn coward. If he said something about her under his breath, he could damn well say it to her face.

Jirou stood at the top of the stairs, staring down at him and looking a mixture of hurt and offended. Katsuki knew he should feel bad about putting such a look on her face, since Jirou was one of the few people in his class that he could actually stand and that didn't seem to be

as fucking stupid and noisy as the rest of his friends – he could almost hear Deku's disapproving, scolding *Kacchan!* –, but if he was being honest with himself, he couldn't care less at that moment, in that context. He hadn't told her any lie, and Deku wasn't fucking awake to reprehend him for *being a meany* or whatever the fuck he would think.

"What do you *mean*?", Jirou insisted, sounding like she honestly didn't know why Katsuki was fucking calling her out. And honestly? He wasn't about to sugarcoat things for her. He had bigger issues at his hands, and little time to solve them.

"I mean you have the means to find out why the fuck shitty Deku is halfway in his grave, but you refuse to do it 'cause you're scared you'll get caught", Katsuki accused. "Which means I'll do it myself, because I don't need your shitty help, and I damn well don't need a coward trailing after me".

He walked out of the dorm and let the door close behind him, trailing down the street towards the teacher's dorms. Since he wouldn't have Earphone Girl's help, he would have to recur to plan B – which consisted of waking Deku the fuck up and launching him like a projectile inside the damn bedroom. This wasn't ideal or best-case scenario, but it was what he could work with at that moment.

"Wait", he heard Jirou call after him, but he didn't stop walking – he merely slowed his pace so that she could catch up with him, even though he'd never admit to doing so. He didn't look at her as she approached him. "I really don't know what you mean, Bakugou. Todoroki had told me he wanted me to eavesdrop an UA board meeting, and I knew it had to do with Midoriya, but he never got into details. When I told him 'no', he didn't even insist on the matter. What do you mean he's halfway dead?", she explained.

Katsuki looked at her through the corner of his eyes, finding sincere concern etched on her face. She was still walking alongside him, and though he didn't want her shitty help anymore, he knew that things would be easier with it. Her quirk was perfect to do what he needed to do, and Deku didn't seem to be anywhere close to waking up or being coherent enough to obtain crucial information.

He stopped on his tracks, Jirou stopping right beside him. He turned to look at her, impatience and annoyance evident in his eyes, but instead of snapping at her, he sighed again, a grumpy scowl painting his face.

"They're not letting people visit Deku anymore", he started, resuming his walk.

"I heard", Jirou nodded with sobriety. "I tried to visit him with Momo and Todoroki, but Recovery Girl told us we couldn't go in".

"That's because his body is fucked up", Katsuki explained. Jirou's eyes widened slightly. "He's wasting away. His immune system has gone to shit, and people can't be around him or he could get even worse. I didn't see it, but Deku did. He went into the room, since he can phase through walls and all that shit. He said it looked bad, and fuck if I know what's going to happen if he actually kicks the bucket".

Jirou stared up at him, the concern in her eyes increasing by a tenfold.

“No one is telling us shit about that, though, and I think it’s only right I get to know what the hell is going on, because I’m the one who’s stuck with the damn nerd. They’re not even telling his mom”, he scoffed.

“That’s…”, Jirou frowned, disapproval etched in her worried face. She seemed at a loss for words, so Katsuki filled in the blanks for her.

“Fucked up”.

“Yeah”, she nodded, pursing her lips into a thin, serious line.

“All Might has been spending most his time searching for the villain who did this and clearly knows more than he fucking lets on”, Katsuki added. “He told me *why* they were keeping Deku from getting visitors, but he didn’t tell me why Deku’s body is turning into shit so fast. And *that’s* what I want to fucking know”, he fixed his gaze on her. “If there’s something that can be done about it, then I’ll fucking get to it. But I can’t solve a fucking problem if I don’t know what it even is”.

Jirou studied his face for a few moments, looking like she was trying to make a decision.

“I’ll do it”, Katsuki added after a pregnant silence, shrugging and consequently having to adjust Deku once again. He averted his gaze from her, and stared straight ahead instead as they continued walking side by side. “With or without your damn help”.

Jirou took a deep breath and looked away, conflicted. It didn’t take her too long to fix her eyes on Katsuki again, determined. She nodded at him.

“I’m going with you”.

Katsuki suppressed a smirk and gave her a scoff instead.

“If it’s to help Midoriya, then I’ll…”, she bit her lower lip in hesitation. “I’ll help. I didn’t know things were this bad”, she added in an attempt at justification.

“Well”, Katsuki said, a serious look on his face as he continued to stare straight ahead. Jirou stared up at him with a frown. “Let’s just fucking hope it’s not *that* bad”.

“You’re absolutely positive Midoriya can’t just sneak into the bedroom?”

Katsuki poked the boy's head in an attempt to wake him up, but it simply lolled limply to the side.

"Oi. Shitty nerd. Wake the fuck up", he hissed, poking it again. The boy continued to sleep, a thin streak of drool leaking from the corner of his mouth.

Katsuki spared the boy another look and sighed.

"He's out cold".

Jirou shook her head.

"You shouldn't have let him drink".

"He didn't fucking drink. *I* did. And it wasn't even that much".

Jirou raised an eyebrow and said nothing.

"*What*?"

She stayed silent.

"Just speak your fucking mind, Ears".

"I just didn't take you for a drinker, that's all".

"I'm *not* a fucking drinker", he said, a bit too defensively. "If you had a fucking ghost glued to your back all the time, draining your fucking energy, and rambling at your fucking ears for weeks, you'd want to have a booze, too".

She stared at him, but said nothing. Katsuki scoffed at her and looked away as she went back to assessing their current situation.

"Fine, then. I can stretch my Earphone Jack to a maximum of 6 meters. The radius of detectable sound I can capture is of 12 meters, but since we are in a really quiet environment, I think I can stretch it to about 14, 15 meters tops. That would mean we need to be at least 21 meters away from All Might's room for me to be able to hear anything".

Katsuki nodded silently at her from where they were both crouching behind a bush. The teachers' dorm was several meters away from them, and All Might's room was still lit up, which meant that the man was luckily in there and still awake.

Katsuki had been aware that there was a chance they would arrive at the teachers' dorm and All Might wouldn't even be there – after all, he was barely around anymore ever since Izuku was hit with the villain's quirk, always out trying to find clues –, but if that had been the case, then they would just have to spy on someone else instead – Aizawa sensei, or perhaps even go all the way to the infirmary to eavesdrop on Recovery Girl.

In fact, now that he found himself kneeling and hunching behind a bush in the middle of the night with Earphone Girl and barely the rough draft of a plan, Katsuki realized that *maybe* he

should have thought this through a bit harder. He could hardly be called an impulsive person, but he was feeling lightheaded and there had been a bad feeling nagging at his brain for a few days, now.

Deku had felt cold a few days before.

Were ghosts even supposed to feel fucking *cold*?

He hadn't thought much about that on the day it happened, being so shaken and riled up by his nightmare and all. But, after several days of not touching Deku and not acknowledging what had happened, he had a lot of time to think back to the cuddling session they had shared and what, exactly, that had meant. And thinking back to the cuddling meant thinking back to the factor that resulted on the cuddling in the first place, which was – cold Deku.

Deku couldn't feel wind. Deku couldn't feel any fucking thing unless Katsuki was touching him directly. So how the fuck had he felt fucking cold? To the point of making *Katsuki* feel it as well?

He had no idea what that truly meant, but he knew that couldn't be good. And it most likely had to do with the fact that Deku was literally dying in an infirmary room, while they went to classes and talked and got drunk as if nothing terrible was happening just a few blocks away. As if Deku himself wasn't decaying a few blocks away.

The truth was Katsuki had gotten too comfortable. Seeing Deku 24/7 on a daily basis had made him forget that they still had an issue at hands – they were still dealing with a situation in which a soul had been detached from its body. That wasn't natural, and there was no way in *hell* Deku was out of the woods just because he was still around to piss Katsuki off.

For some reason, he ended up wondering what would happen if Deku actually died. Would his soul be stuck with Katsuki forevermore, or would it simply disappear, disintegrating away from existence in front of his very eyes?

He shook his head, treading away from that idea. Deku wasn't going to fucking die. Katsuki would march his way into hell and drag his shitty soul back by the hair if he fucking had to.

He didn't know why he felt like that, but he just did – which was ironic, since he spent most of his life hating Deku's fucking guts. He never wanted the shitty nerd to die, but that didn't mean he hadn't hated him at some point.

But now – now that Katsuki didn't hate him anymore, now that Katsuki could even admit (albeit only internally) to feeling a bit of f-word for the boy – Deku dying wasn't an option. He wasn't about to let it fucking happen.

But in order to prevent it from fucking happening, he needed to figure out exactly what the hell was going on with the damn nerd, and why his body was wasting away so fast.

Looking atop the leaves shielding them away from view, Katsuki spotted another bush, still far away from the building but closer to All Might's room. He nudged at Jirou and nodded at his target.

“You think you can hear him from there?”, he asked, voice barely above a whisper. She studied the bush and the distance from the building for a while, trying to make the proper calculations. Eventually, she nodded, turning to look at him.

“I think so. The only problem is getting there without being spotted”, she replied in an equal tone, her lips pursing into a thin line.

“Should have brought the fucking Invisible Girl with us”, Katsuki scoffed in self-scolding, glaring at the leaves in front of him and at Deku’s sleeping form, which was splayed on the ground and now snoring softly.

“I don’t see how that would help us. She would manage to get there unspotted, but she can’t make *others* invisible. And I’m the one with the Earphone Jack”, she waved the jacks in front of him for emphasis.

“She could have sneaked in closer or even into the bedroom”, Katsuki grunted, annoyed at himself for jumping into impulsive conclusions instead of thinking the plan through first. *That* was precisely why he always thought things through – this way, he didn’t risk getting into a catch-22 like he was right now. Deep down, he wanted to blame Deku for flooding him with his impulsiveness and dumbness, but Katsuki knew that the nerd had nothing to do with that. This had been his own fault, his own mistake. Not that he would admit it out loud.

“I think that would be riskier than having me hear from the distance”, Jirou commented, staring at their intended hideout and trying to figure out a way to get there without calling attention. “You clearly don’t know Hagakure if you think she can sneak into a place unnoticed just because she’s invisible”.

“Well, what’s the point of her fucking quirk, then?”, Katsuki frowned.

“She’s working on it”, Jirou replied absentmindedly, turning to him again. “I think if we head back a bit and crawl behind those bushes over there, we can get to the one closer to All Might’s room”, she said, pointing at a series of bushes behind then. Katsuki thought about the suggestion for a moment, before nodding his agreement.

They silently crawled their way to the bushes on the back, before heading to the one closer to All Might’s room. It would be too troublesome for Katsuki to carry Izuku alongside with him, so he let him lay on the floor and trusted the soulbond they shared to carry the nerd for him. This often-tired Katsuki out more than carrying Deku in his arms did, but at least he didn’t risk getting caught this way.

They hid behind the bush closer to All Might’s room, and Jirou gave Katsuki a tiny nod before stretching her Earphone Jack to its maximum 6-meter length. The thin cord was mostly unnoticeable in the darkness of the night, even if it was coming out from inside a bush and planted in the middle of a pathway. She held one hand to her ear and concentration flooded her face, as she did her best to hear into All Might’s room.

For several minutes in a row, Jirou could hear nothing other than the sound of typing, a foot tapping on the floor and the eventual floorboard creak whenever All Might stood up. He was alone in his room, and thus there was no reason for him to speak out loud.

“So? Anything?”, Katsuki asked with a whisper after a while. Jirou looked at him, her head still tilted and one hand still held up to her ear.

“No”, she shook her head, mouthing the words. “He’s alone. Typing something”.

Katsuki pursed his lips and looked away, angry. This was why shitty Icy Hot’s plan was better, even though he didn’t want to admit so – eavesdropping an UA board meeting was bound to give them information, however small, since the members of the board would be there with the sole goal of *discussing things aloud*. Eavesdropping on All Might’s bedroom was an entirely different matter – he was alone, and had no reason to simply speak up about Izuku’s condition to an empty room. They would need to be very fucking lucky in order to get out of there with any sort of information.

On the other hand, Icy Hot’s plan was worse in the sense that, had a bunch of 1st years been caught eavesdropping on a confidential board meeting, they were bound to face expulsion, whereas being caught by All Might alone would probably result in a lighter punishment – especially because All Might, as much as them, only wanted to help Izuku.

They stayed there, crouching behind a bush, for around ten minutes. Katsuki was starting to grow impatient, which was never favorable at environments in which he needed to be quiet, and Jirou’s arm was starting to cramp for staying in the same position for too long. These ten minutes that had passed felt like an hour, and they were both starting to get impatient with All Might’s silence and their uncomfortable position on the cold, hard floor.

“I don’t think we’ll get anything out of this”, Jirou mouthed at Katsuki after a while. Everything she had managed to capture so far was the sound of typing and breathing. Not a single word from All Might – not a single answer to their questions.

“Keep listening”, Katsuki instructed, staring at All Might’s window. He wouldn’t just fucking give up after ten minutes. They had come all the way there.

“Couldn’t we try to hear Aizawa sensei’s bedroom?”, Jirou suggested, shifting on the floor so that she could crouch in a more comfortable position. Her legs were becoming sore as well, her arms already cramping. She was shivering from the cold of the night, having dressed for a party at the dorm, and not a stakeout in the open.

Katsuki rolled his eyes and removed his jacket, throwing it atop her shoulders. He needed her to be on the top of her game in order for this night not to be a total waste of time. Jirou blushed slightly and looked away from him, clutching the jacket closer to herself and being thankful for the warmth it provided.

“If All Might catches us, he won’t tell on us”, Katsuki explained in a low voice, still staring at the teacher’s window. “We’ll probably just receive one hell of a scolding. If Aizawa sensei catches us –“, Katsuki shook his head. “We’ll be royally fucked”.

Jirou pursed her lips, taking his words into consideration. He was right, of course, so she stayed where she was, jack still plugged on the floor, and listening with attention to anything she could.

“Kacchan…?”, Izuku asked from where he was lying on his belly in the middle of the pathway, right in view.

When Katsuki crawled his way to the bush in front of All Might’s bedroom, the soulbond he shared with Izuku had dragged the sleeping nerd behind him, as he had expected it to. However, as they knew very well, there was a maximum distance they could get from each other without dragging one another along. When Katsuki reached the bush, Izuku was left laying several meters away from them, in the middle of the pathway. Thankfully, Katsuki was the only one who could see or hear him, so he had left the nerd there. Going back and grabbing him would risk giving away his presence there, and it wasn’t like anyone would be able to see him anyway. When they got the information they wanted and left, Izuku would be eventually dragged behind him again, and once they were a safe distance away from view, Katsuki could go back the remaining distance between them and carry the nerd once again.

“Kacchan?”, Izuku asked again, lifting his head off the floor and looking around with squinted, glazed eyes. Katsuki sighed and eyerolled.

He couldn’t exactly call Izuku or wave at him, since that could end up revealing their position in case a teacher was looking out the window or passing by. So Katsuki stayed there, completely silent, staring at the drunk Izuku from the distance and waiting until the nerd’s eyes looked at his general direction. He wasn’t about to risk giving himself away just because of a drunk ghost nerd.

“Hnngh”, Izuku groaned and turned so that he was lying on his back, instead of his belly. He stayed like that for so long that Katsuki assumed he had fallen asleep again, until the nerd pushed himself into a sitting position and toppled to the side in lack of balance. Katsuki rolled his eyes again.

“Anything?”, Katsuki mouthed at Jirou. She looked at him and shook her head no.

He went back to looking at the wriggling Deku with a stern look on his face. The nerd was having trouble getting to his feet, tumbling to the side and losing balance several times over. Every time he collided with the floor, Katsuki could fucking feel it. It was getting a bit annoyed by that, if he had to be honest.

“Things would have been way easier if you had just agreed to Todoroki’s plan”, Jirou whispered, groaning and shifting on the floor in the search of a better position again. Katsuki glared at her.

“I could tell you the fucking same. And I thought Icy Hot hadn’t gone into details with you”, he pointed out, irritated. Jirou didn’t look at him, still focused on her mission.

“He didn’t”, she explained, voice quiet. “But he did say he had asked for your help, and that you didn’t want to get involved. I’m just tying the dots together”.

Katsuki continued to stare at her, which made her stare back.

“What? He obviously wanted you to sneak Midoriya into the board meeting”, she shrugged. “That would have been the safest option, since no one other than you can see him. When you

refused, he came looking for me. Despite what you may think, I'm not thick in the head".

"Clearly fucking not", Katsuki huffed, shifting on the floor as well. Izuku had made it to his feet, but he was stumbling in a zombie-like way as he looked around in search of Katsuki, who rolled his eyes at the sight.

"Then what changed?", Jirou continued.

Katsuki sighed in annoyance.

"The fuck do you mean?"

She looked at him.

"Well, Todoroki offered you a safe plan and you refused. Now, you're crouching in front of one of our senseis' room, trying to eavesdrop on him. Your solution seems to be more dangerous, but you're still willing to do it. Something must have changed in the meantime, if you turned down a safe plan and are now willing to do a reckless one".

This is your fault. And you're not even sorry, are you?

He looked away and pursed his lips.

"I didn't want to fucking work with Icy Hot", he offered as an explanation, even though the excuse sounded weak to his own ears. Before Jirou could point that out, he added: "Now stay fucking quiet before someone hears us".

Jirou stared at him for a bit longer.

"I'm just saying Todoroki's plan was less risky".

And then she fell quiet.

Katsuki fumed. Why the fuck was Icy Hot always a point of comparison with him? And why the fuck did this fucking emo girl feel the need to point that out every other fucking second?

"Tell me how the fuck you think getting caught by the fucking UA board and Principal Nezu is less risky than getting caught by All Might alone", he growled in irritation. Jirou sighed.

"You don't know if you would be caught. And I thought we were going to be quiet".

"You fucking brought this upon yourself".

"I was just making a comment".

"Yeah, when I didn't fucking ask you to. If you fucking like to kiss Icy Hot's ass so much, keep it to your damn self".

Jirou turned to look at him.

"Why do you have to be like that?"

“Like fucking *what*?”

“An asshole. I’m only trying to help Midoriya, just as much as you are, and I’m reasonably worried we’ll get caught if we stay here too long. You don’t have to be so rude, *or* self-righteous, for that matter”.

“Don’t be such a hypocrite. You’re only trying to help yourself”.

Jirou squinted her eyes at him, indignant.

“Excuse me?”

“What? You didn’t fucking agree to tag along until I said you weren’t a hero. You’re only here to prove that you are one, so don’t pretend this is because you want to hold hands with Deku and dance with him in a garden full of flowers once he’s fucking recovered”.

Jirou shifted on the floor so that she could get a better look at Katsuki, offense written in her whole body.

“Is that what you really think?”

“Yeah, it fucking is”.

She was silent for a moment, shaking her head at him.

“I didn’t agree to come before because I didn’t know Midoriya’s state was so bad. The only reason I’m here is because I want to help him in the best way I can. I’m sure he would do the same for me, if I was in his place”.

Katsuki scoffed and gave her a mocking smirk, looking away and ignoring her.

“*And* I want to help him because he’s my friend”, she continued, angry. “You’re the only one who’s here to save your own ass”.

It was Katsuki’s turn to glare at her with indignation.

“The fuck did you say?”

“You said it yourself. You don’t know what will happen if he dies. If he does and his soul is still attached to yours…”, she trailed off, pursing her lips into a thin, stern line.

And fuck, *okay*, Katsuki had actually thought about that scenario, but he always concluded it with ‘there’s no reason to think about this because Deku won’t die’. But now that Jirou had said the fucking words, things became too real.

There *was* a real chance Deku could die, and, if he did, Katsuki didn’t know what would happen. So far, the possibilities he had come up with were either being stuck with Deku for the rest of his life or watching Deku disappear in front of his eyes. He had never even fucking considered the fucking chance that… That…

That if Deku died while still soulbound to him, then he would die as well.

Because that was what Jirou meant when she said he was trying to save his own ass, right? That there was a chance he would die as well if Deku did?

And yeah, it only made sense that she saw the situation like that. He had never been Deku's friend. He had only ever mistreated him publicly, and humiliated him, and harassed him. It was only logical that Jirou tried to find a reason why Katsuki, Deku's fucking bully, would suddenly be so interested in helping him and reached the conclusion that he was only trying to help himself. His relationship with Deku had only developed after the boy became a ghost, and even so, he didn't exactly spend time with Jirou for the girl to realize that sudden change of behavior.

He stared at her, not knowing how to respond. What could he possibly say to defend himself? 'I know this sounds off but I don't hate Deku anymore and I actually give a shit that he might be dying'? 'I'm worried about the state of his body and he was feeling cold the other day so I want to help him before it's too late'? 'I had a nightmare in which he blamed me for his death and I want to prevent that from happening even though it was just a fucking dream'? 'I promised his mom I would keep him safe'? 'I kind of almost care about him'?

"That's doesn't fucking concern you", he ended up spitting instead, in his usual grumpy, angry tone. "Just keep listening to fucking All Might and stay out of my damn business".

He was trying to be better, but it was honestly not worth it sometimes. It certainly wasn't worth having Earphone Girl think he was a damn emotional loser.

People had always told him, throughout his life, that he behaved more like a villain than a hero. The fucking League had kidnapped him because of that same assumption. People always seem to think the worst of him, anyway – so Katsuki couldn't care less if Jirou thought he only wanted to help Deku to save himself. He would rather have her think that than to have her think he wanted to help Deku because he *liked* him.

Even though he did kind of sort of almost liked Deku now, it didn't mean he wanted people to *know* that. Or tease him for that. Or make fucking uncalled-for comments about his sudden change in behavior.

Jirou turned away from him and continued to listen to All Might's bedroom quietly.

They stayed silent for a long while, Jirou paying attention on whatever she could capture from All Might and Katsuki moping beside her. He was basically glaring as Deku stumbled and almost fell on his face, still searching for him. Of all the times the nerd could have woken the fuck up… At least no one other than Katsuki could hear or see the shitshow he was pulling.

Eventually, he spotted Katsuki hiding behind the bush with Jirou, and Katsuki had to pretend that the way Deku's face lit up in pure happiness once he finally saw him didn't do weird things to his chest. He could only be thankful that Deku's was probably too wasted to realize that feeling as being Katsuki's.

The drunk boy stumbled his way towards Katsuki with a cheerful yell of “Kacchan!”, before stumbling one final time and falling right on the top of Katsuki’s lap with a giggle. Katsuki, comprehensively, jolted, trying to remove the heavy Deku from the top of him and startling Jirou in the process.

“What’s going on?”, she asked with an urgent whisper as Katsuki struggled against an invisible Deku’s weight.

Deku, on his own turn, was wriggling and clinging to Katsuki as if he was a lifeline, sitting on lap and enveloping him with his legs around his waist and his arms around his neck. Katsuki’s eyes widened in embarrassment and fury at this and he tried to shove Izuku away, but it was fruitless – the boy had buried his face on Katsuki’s neck and was holding onto him for dear life. If Katsuki kept moving so much, he would end up making too much noise – he had already rattled the bush shielding them too hard –, so all he could do was sit still and hold Deku before the little asshole found a way to fall off him and hit his damn head.

“Bakugou?”, Jirou insisted when he offered her no answer, frowning in urgency and concern. He stared at her, thankful that at least she couldn’t really see Deku and, consequently, didn’t know that he was sitting in Katsuki’s lap with his legs spread around his waist. Because that would be fucking *hard* to explain.

“Deku woke up”, he told her simply, not getting into details. Jirou blinked blankly at him.

“Well, don’t you think we should send him in, then?” she suggested. “This way he can at least get a look at whatever it is All Might’s been typing for so long”.

Katsuki tilted his head in order to get a proper look at Deku. He was sobbing quietly, face still buried against his neck, his tears running down Katsuki’s shoulder.

“He’s too drunk to go in”, he added, not meeting her eyes. He could tell she was still staring at him, but didn’t look to check it out.

“Are you –“

“Yeah, I’m fucking *sure*. Just keep listening. If he gets better, I’ll launch him in”.

Jirou sent him a final suspicious look before turning away and going back to eavesdropping on their teacher. Izuku continued to cry against his shoulder.

“The fuck are you crying about now?”, Katsuki nudged Izuku as quietly as he could, not wanting Jirou to hear their conversation. He couldn’t feel any sadness coming from the nerd, so all the tears and sobs didn’t really add up. Izuku buried his face harder against Katsuki’s neck, his damn curls making his fucking skin tingle.

“Thought you’d left me”, Izuku said, voice muffled by Katsuki’s skin. Katsuki frowned.

“What?”

“I thought… I thought y-you’d left me”, Izuku explained, clinging harder to him.

“How the fuck would I leave you, shitty nerd? Our souls are fucking bound to each other. Is it really hard to use your brain once in a while?”, he whispered.

“I couldn’ see you”, Izuku continued, gasping. He sounded like he was calming down, even though his cheeks were still moist. “I – I couldn’. Thought I was alon’. That no one could see me…”

Katsuki sighed, holding him tighter and glaring at the distance. He couldn’t deny that all the sudden physical contact after days of no touching was a bit too much for his increasingly sober state, but he was still too lightheaded to care – no longer from the booze, but from the adrenaline.

They could get caught at any moment. And it wasn’t like Katsuki could shake the surprisingly strong drunk Deku off him without making a scene anyway, so all he could do was accept it and deal with it.

“I can see you just fine, asshole”, he said as a very Katsuki-like form of reassurance, which included scolding and name-calling. “Now shut the fuck up. We’re in the middle of a stakeout”.

Izuku lifted his head at this, staring at Katsuki with excited, albeit still glassy eyes.

“Who’re we stakin’?”, he slurred.

“All Might”, Katsuki responded simply. “I intend to get to the bottom of this shit”.

“All Might? Wher’s he?”, Izuku slurred with cheerfulness, trying to look past Katsuki’s shoulder and consequently shoving him against the bush, whose leaves shook noisily with the movement. Jirou pointed him with a sharp disapproving look and Katsuki was forced to hold Izuku tighter.

“The fuck did I just tell you? Be fucking quiet, dumbass”, he scolded the drunken boy, who had been reduced to giggling fit as he was pushed back into Katsuki’s lap. Katsuki found that their embarrassing position was the least of his concerns at the moment – his top priority was getting the drunk nerd to calm the fuck down and stop being so disruptive.

“Wanna see All Might”, Izuku protested drunkenly, allowing himself to be held by Katsuki. “I really like’m”.

“Yeah, tell me the fuck about it”.

“Huh?”

“Just stay quiet, Deku”.

“But I wanna see… You said we were putting All Might on a stake…”

“That’s not what I fucking said”.

“I don’t wan’ him to die, Kaccha’!”

“I fucking know. Stop talking”.

“Why you burnin’ him…”

“Deku, I swear to fucking god”.

“Hmmph”, he buried his face on Katsuki’s neck again, who turned to catch a glimpse of Jirou. She was staring at him with a weird look.

“*What*?”, he asked her sharply. She stared at him for a long moment before responding.

“Still nothing”, she provided simply, going back to hearing.

“Why’s everything twirlin’…?”, Izuku asked after a while.

“Because you’re fucking drunk”.

Izuku started to giggle.

“I’m tired of bein’ drunk. Go ahead ‘n turn me on”.

Katsuki blinked blankly.

“*What*”.

“Turn me on and off”, Izuku said simply. “That’s wha’ you do with a computer when the computer can’t see straight”, he giggled again.

Katsuki gritted his teeth.

“It’s the other way around, asshole”.

“Wha’?”

“You gotta turn it off before you turn it back on”.

“As if you coul’ turn me off, Kaccha’”, he giggled hard, clinging to the front of Katsuki’s shirt. Katsuki felt his face burn, but decided that it was in anger. Izuku wasn’t making any fucking sense, and it – it pissed him off.

“The *fuck* is that supposed to mean?”, he asked, feeling angry even though he couldn’t tell why.

“Huh?”, Izuku asked, clearly too out of it to even understand what Katsuki was talking about. Trying to talk to him in this state was fruitless – and it became obvious that any hopes he had of sending Deku in to spy on All Might were fruitless, too.

“Nothing. Go take a nap”, he ended up saying, trying to get the drunk nerd to shut up.

“Don’ wanna”.

“I don’t give a shit. Fall asleep or I’ll fucking make you”.

“Hnngghhh, mean”, Izuku sighed, supporting his cheek on Katsuki’s shoulder and going silent. After a couple minutes his body relaxed, and his arms around Katsuki’s neck went limp. Izuku slumped against Katsuki, who held his sleeping form in place.

He looked at Jirou again. She was still giving him that weird look.

“I think he’s going to sleep, now”, she said after some minutes of silence, shaking her head in defeat. Katsuki had to blink at her for a couple seconds before he realized she was talking about All Might, and not Izuku. His anger increased by a tenfold.

“Are you fucking *kidding me*?”, Katsuki whispered in fury. All this fucking effort for nothing?

“No. He was in the bathroom a couple minutes ago, and now his mattress just rattled. I can hear him pulling the covers”, she provided, focused. Then, she looked up at Katsuki again. “I don’t think we’ll get anything out of him today”.

“Fuck”, Katsuki shook his head in anger, glaring at the floor. His hands tightened into fists. “*Fuck*”.

Jirou gave him a look that was halfway between apologetic and sympathetic.

“Look, I –“, and then she cut herself off, eyes unfocused. Katsuki frowned at her, waiting for her to continue. She didn’t.

“Oi”, he called, sitting up straighter and his instincts flaring up in high alert. “What’s going on?”

“Hold”, she instructed simply, eyes still unfocused. She held up a finger at him to indicate that he should be quiet and her other hand found its way to her ear again. He would usually feel angry if someone cut him off like that, but now he had higher matters at hands. “His phone’s vibrating”, Jirou supplied after a few tense seconds, focused and not looking at Katsuki.

Katsuki watched silently as Jirou shifted on the floor again, trying her best to hear what was happening. Inside the room, All Might picked up the phone. Jirou could only hear his side of the conversation – her quirk was already stretched to its maximum from that distance and hearing All Might alone already took all of her concentration.

“Yes?”, All Might answered the call. The other person spoke, to which he replied: “Oh. Hi. Do you have any news?”

She blinked, concentrated.

“… I see. And the location? Hmm. Yes, yes, of course, I understand”.

She squinted her eyes. Maybe if she tried a bit harder, she could hear the other side of the –

“But you do understand time is running short, right?”

She paused.

“Our two last missions went wrong, and now Young Midoriya only has five more days before the quirk...”, a pregnant pause, a sigh. “Well. If we are going to act, we need to do it now. We can’t afford to wait like the last time”.

She blinked. *What*?

“Of course, I understand. And you are sure they will be there tomorrow?”

She held her breath.

“Understood. Thank you for your help. I will inform Aizawa and the others about this. Right after sunset, you say?”

She held her breath.

“All right. Thank you, my friend. I really appreciate your help. Oh, and…”

She blinked in anticipation.

“You are positive about the quirk’s deadline?”

Her face became pale.

“… Of course. I understand. You can’t blame me for hoping”.

She couldn’t quite breathe.

“Yes, yes. It’s only…”, All Might sighed in grief. “Young Midoriya is very important to me, as you know. To know he only has five more days, it… it’s truly…”, he sighed out a shaky breath, as if he was dealing with strong emotion. “I had hoped there could be a time difference from victim to victim, but from what you’ve said… Yes, of course. I’ll inform everyone. Thank you again”.

Beep.

A sigh, heavy. All Might’s heart was thumping heavy in his chest.

Beep beep beep beep.

“Aizawa. Yes, I have news. Hosu, tomorrow after sunset. Yes, he assured me they will be there. We can make a capture then. No, of course. But if we fail, I’m afraid…”

Jirou took a hand to her lips in shock. Katsuki’s crimson eyes were burning holes into her, but she couldn’t pay him any attention right then. She needed to listen – she needed to hear –

“Yes. I trust you to spread the word. I need to get some sleep, now, I have been awake for almost two days… We all need to be at our best shape if we plan on doing this”.

A pause.

“Yes. I agree. I will contact Mrs. Midoriya at first light. Thank you”.

Beep.

Jirou heard the covers shuffling again, a bottle opening, water being gulped, and a glass being set on a hard surface. Only when All Might’s breathing evened out several tense minutes later, indicating he had fallen asleep, did she remove her jack from the floor and fell back away from the bushes, still looking very pale and frantic.

Midoriya was dying. Her classmate Midoriya would die in five days.

“So? What the fuck did you hear?”, Katsuki asked her, staring down at the girl’s pale, terrified face with worry and dread forming at the pit of his stomach. Jirou had felt the intensity of Katsuki’s stare throughout the entire time she had spent listening to All Might, and she could tell how eager he was to know what she had learned. She looked up at him, unable to control the wideness of her eyes, not even for his sake.

If she told him about Midoriya right there and then, he was bound to lose it. Bakugou’s temperament was explosive in the best of days – she could only imagine how badly he would react to knowing that Midoriya would die in less than a week. And if he made any sort of explosion or screaming there, right in front of the teachers’ dorms in the middle of the night, they were bound to receive one hell of a punishment.

She needed to stay calm. She needed to think things through, rationally and coldly. She needed to act like a hero, and heroes always did what was best for the situation and for the people involved.

Her hands couldn’t stop shaking and her heart was pounding inside her chest, because *Midoriya would die in five days*, but she needed to keep her cool. If not for her own sake, then for Bakugou’s – he would need someone with a cool head to at least try to prevent him from blowing up half of the UA grounds.

Fine. She could do this. It would be hard, but she could do this. Breathe in, breathe out. Breathe in, breathe out. In the worst-case scenario, she could always shock him using her jacks and drag his stunned body back to the student dorms before he could go on a rampage.

“Bakugou”, she whispered, voice shaky but tone firm. “I need to know you won’t lose it”.

“Just *tell me*”, he replied sharply, instantly, without giving her any space to finish the sentence. She could see how on edge he was – which was only reasonable, since he had no idea what All Might had said and all he had seen was Jirou’s face getting paler and her eyes getting wider with each word she heard.

Jirou looked around, swallowing dry and looking like she was holding the weight of the world on her shoulders. She shook her head, making a decision.

“We need to get out of here. We can’t talk about this here”, she said, making to stand up. Katsuki held her wrist, holding her in place before she could go any farther.

“Just fucking tell me. What did All Might say?”, he demanded through gritted teeth, impatient. His grip on her wrist was tight, but not with anger – with concern. Her reaction hadn’t been good. Nothing about this seemed good.

Izuku was still fast asleep on his lap.

“Let’s go back to the main street”, Jirou said, and there was a nervous pleading in her tone, which contrasted a lot with her snarky attitude from mere minutes ago.

Noticing how badly her hands were shaking and how pale her face looked, Katsuki sighed angrily and relented, despite his urgency. He wouldn’t be getting anything out of her right there.

He adjusted Izuku against him, passing his arms beneath the boy’s armpits to hold him in place as if he were a baby, despite of how ridiculous that sight seemed. Katsuki stood up, Izuku’s arms hugging his neck again and his legs fastened around Katsuki’s waist. At least this would be better and easier than dragging the shitty nerd across the floor with their soulbond.

As quickly and quietly as they could, Katsuki and Jirou rushed away from the teachers’ dorm and reentered the main street, heading towards the students’ dorm.

“Ok, now spit it the fuck out”, Katsuki instructed once they were far away from the teachers’ views and ear ranges. He adjusted Izuku against him as Jirou tried to catch her breath and looked around frantically, deeply worried. She was shaking and her face was still pale, which wasn’t doing wonders for Katsuki’s nerve.

He grabbed her forearm with one hand while he supported Deku against him with the other, trying to help her focus, and stared deeply into her eyes with no less concern. He had never seen Jirou quite so shaken – which only increased the sense of dread bottling up in the pit of his stomach. Whatever she had heard – whatever All Might had said – it hadn’t been good.

“What did you hear, Ears?”, he asked, firm. He needed to know.

She stared up at him, frantic and hesitant, opening and closing her mouth several times over as if she didn’t know how to start.

“I – I need you to promise me you won’t freak out”, she ended up blurting out, much to Katsuki’s growing impatience.

“I won’t”, he said emphatically.

“*Or* do anything stupid –“

“I fucking *won’t*”, he interrupted, getting angrier by the second. His eyes were fixed on hers, shining crimson in the moonlight. They were as sober as she had ever seen them – angry, but

not in their usual berserker way. There was something different about them – something new shining in them. “Just tell me what the fuck is it”, he added after a pregnant pause.

She took in a deep breath and nodded her head. She still looked nervous – but Katsuki’s sobriety reminded her of what she needed to do.

He was stuck with Midoriya’s soul. He needed to know.

He needed to know, if they had any chance of stopping Midoriya from… from…

“Midoriya… He’s – I couldn’t understand everything, just bits and pieces, but from what I could get – from what All Might said – he…”, she trailed off, shaking her head and giving Katsuki the most serious apologetic look he had ever seen directed at him in his life. “The quirk that hit him. It works with some sort of deadline”.

Katsuki stared down at her, his grasp on her arm unrelenting.

“All Might said Midoriya only has five more days before he…”, she trailed off again, swallowing dry.

Katsuki squeezed her arm. *Fuck no*.

“Before he *what*?”

Jirou let out a shaky breath.

“Before he *dies*, Bakugou. He only has five more days before he dies”.

Katsuki stared down at her, his hand still squeezing her arm.

He had never felt so sober in his entire life.

Suddenly, all thoughts of Icy Hot and Class 1-A and All Might disappeared from his mind as if they had never been there in the first place, as if they were nothing, absolutely nothing, in the face of what Jirou had just told him.

He was oddly numb.

The only things he could feel was Deku’s weight against him.

The slow beat of Deku’s heart.

The tingle of his curls against his chin.

His warm breath against his neck.

Him.

Just him.

He only felt Deku.

“Are… Are you okay, Bakugou?”

“Y-You’re not… You’re not saying anything, and it’s kind of freaking me out”.

“Did you hear what I said? Are you with me?”

“Bakugou”.

“Bakugou!”

“God. I don’t know what’s going on, just *say* something”.

She sighed.

“Look, he – All Might, he said something about a capture tomorrow”.

Katsuki looked at her.

“So there’s a good chance they’ll bring this guy in before anything can happen to Midoriya, ok? Before anything can happen to you. Let’s try not to worry so much”.

“I know how hard it is to trust UA right now, but – it’s All Might we’re talking about. And Aizawa sensei. They’re going to catch this guy. They have to”.

“Where?”

A pause. Jirou blinked at him.

“What?”

“Where will the capture be? Did he mention it?”

Jirou swallowed dry again, looking at him. She said nothing, doubt flashing through her eyes. Katsuki snarled, taking a step closer to her.

“What? You’re not gonna fucking tell me?”

That was the first display of emotion he showed after she told him about the deadline and Izuku’s death. He wasn’t screaming and exploding things like she had expected him to – like she had anticipated him to –, and his cold silence was infinitely scarier than his burning anger.

“What will you do if I tell you?”, Jirou asked cautiously, because she might not be close friends with Katsuki but she still knew him well enough to figure out what he must be planning.

It would be dangerous. It would be illegal. It would be *career suicide*.

If Bakugou tried to go after the pros on this capture mission, he would probably face expulsion. Hell, he would probably be banned from ever getting a hero license.

Her response seemed to anger him. In some messed up way, that gave her relief – the empty, lost and completely uncharacteristic look that had appeared in Katsuki’s eyes for a split moment when she told him Midoriya would die in five days had been worse than any level of rage he could offer her.

She had never seen him like this. She had never thought he could behave like this in the first place.

(She wasn’t even considering the fact that he looked like he was carrying the invisible Midoriya in his arms).

Maybe she had been wrong. Maybe his concern wasn’t only about himself…

… Which only made this entire situation *worse*.

“The fuck do you care what I’ll do, Ears?”, he asked, annoyed. “Just tell me where it will be”.

Jirou hesitated.

“We should head back to the dorms”, she said calmly, raising a hand towards him as she would to a wild animal. Her face was a mixture of serious and concerned. “We can still be caught by a teacher out here. We can about this talk back there –“

“And *what*? Have every single one of those assholes hear about this shit you just told me? Yeah, because there’s *no way* that would fucking backfire”, he snarled.

She stared at him.

What should she *do*?

“I’ll – I’ll tell you everything I heard All Might say”, she promised. “But not here. We can go back to my room, or to yours, whatever suits you. If we get caught now, we won’t be able to do anything”.

Katsuki stared at her for seconds that felt like hours, glaring. This look would have been infinitely more intimidating had he not been holding an invisible Izuku. Instead of nodding, agreeing, or giving Jirou any indication that he had heard her, he simply walked past the girl and headed to the dorms.

He was probably too proud to utter the words “you’re right, let’s go back to the dorms”, Jirou figured. She rolled her eyes and sighed, chasing after the boy once again.

They walked with hurried steps and the weight of the world on their shoulders. Once they arrived at the dorm building, they rushed up the stairs and straight to Katsuki’s floor. When they passed the common room, not even glancing towards its general direction in order not to catch attention, no one noticed their rushed forms, too caught up in Kirishima’s ongoing birthday party.

He was aware that the feeling was stupid, but it made him sick that everyone was still celebrating, and having fun, and laughing their asses off, while Deku lay dying, all by himself, away in an infirmary room. These bastards – himself included – had been having the time of their fucking lives while Deku wasted away with each breath they took, with each day they wasted, with each fucking second they spent doing something other than looking for the damn villain who had attacked him.

Katsuki unlocked his door and nodded for Jirou to go inside, locking it behind them.

He carefully placed Izuku, who was still fast asleep and now snoring, on his side of the bed, and turned to face Jirou. She was standing in the middle of Katsuki’s room, looking awkward as if she didn’t quite know what to do with herself. Funny enough, she wasn’t looking around the room or even feeling glad that she had been granted entrance in a place that so few of their friends had visited – instead, she was staring at Katsuki with worry and fear in her eyes.

Their priorities had changed so much in the past minutes. What once would have baffled Jirou and annoyed Katsuki was now nothing but the necessary background for something way, way bigger than visiting a forbidden room.

Katsuki sighed deeply, approaching her.

“So?”, he urged when the girl stayed silent.

“He… He picked up a call. I don’t know who it was from, someone helping with the investigation, I think. They had information about the villain’s whereabouts. All Might asked them about the ‘quirk’s deadline’ – he… He asked for confirmation that Midoriya really only has five days left”.

Katsuki didn’t move, or react in any way. His eyes were like inferno in the dark.

“He thanked the person and then called Aizawa sensei to let him know. Said something about making a capture that doesn’t fail this time. And – he asked Aizawa sensei to tell others”.

Katsuki kept staring at her.

“And Midoriya’s mother”.

He took in a deep breath, tightening his hands into fists and looking away from her with an ugly, angry snarl on his face.

“Fuck”.

He turned away from her and threw his hands above his head in order to stretch his back. Even in the darkness of the room she could see how tense his shoulders were. The only source of light was coming from the moon outside the half-open window.

Katsuki turned back to her, his face so stoic that Jirou truly had no idea what was going on inside his head at that moment. Was he angry? Was he worried? Was he sad? Was he nervous? She couldn’t tell. All she could see was a hint of his familiar and everlasting grumpiness, but everything beneath that was a mystery.

“And where did he say they were fucking going?”

Jirou hesitated. She knew nothing good would happen if she told him.

And yet… If Midoriya would truly die in merely five days, could she simply just stand aside and do nothing, when she had the means to help? Could she really turn away from the responsibility that had been entrusted to her in the moment she heard All Might’s words? Could she withhold that information from the only other person that might be directly, physically affected by Midoriya’s death?

What kind of hero would that make her?

She had a good quirk. She was an UA student, training to become a pro. If she had such a power, and allowed bad things to happen… Then the bad things would happen because of her. She had a duty – a responsibility.

Midoriya’s death was already their ultimatum. Little seemed to matter in the face of that.

“H-Hosu”, she said, her heart tight and beating fast in her chest. “But Bakugou –“

“Whatever it is you’re going to fucking say, save it”, he interrupted her. He wasn’t even looking at her anymore – one of his hands were supporting his chin, making him look pensive, and his eyes were unfocused, darting across the darkness of his room. It was clear that, now he had gotten what he wanted from Jirou, his attention was no longer on her. He was probably taking in the information she had gathered and trying to come up with a plan – which was exactly what she had feared he would do, and exactly what she was also doing in the moment.

“I want to help”, she ended up saying. He still didn’t look at her. “Midoriya is my friend, too. If there’s anything I can do –“

“No”, was Katsuki’s simple, sharp, emotionless response.

She stared at him.

“You’ve already helped”, he added dismissively, and Jirou could do nothing other than gape at him. Knowing the boy, she was well aware that this was the closest he had ever gotten to showing gratitude towards her.

This was so weird. Finding out Midoriya was dying, being inside Bakugou’s room, spying on All Might, hearing Bakugou say his own version of thank you… It was like the world had been turned upside down ever since Midoriya suffered that attack.

“I know what you’re going to do”, Jirou added after a moment of shocked silence. “And you shouldn’t do it alone”.

“I should *only* do it alone”, Katsuki responded without even looking at her. He was pacing impatiently across his room, looking as serious and focused as ever. Seeing him like this, Jirou would have never been able to tell that the boy in front of her had had a few beers and taken part in a game of truth or dare barely an hour before.

“You’re not –“

“I told you to fucking *save* it, didn’t I, Ears?”, he snapped his head at her, looking a mixture of angry and annoyed. “Just go back to the fucking party and forget everything you heard tonight”.

Jirou squinted her eyes at him, frowning in confusion and indignation.

“What do you mean *forget everything*? Bakugou, I can’t just pretend I didn’t hear what I heard!”, she protested.

“Try really fucking hard, then”, he told her in a snarky way. She scoffed and shook her head.

“I care about Midoriya. I’m not going to step aside and do nothing when there’s something I can do, and *especially* not because you think you can tell me what to do”.

“And what is it that you can fucking do, huh?”, Katsuki snapped at her, and yes, this was a Bakugou that she could recognize. An angry, arrogant Bakugou who put other people down as a way to shut them up – a Bakugou she was familiar with, and that didn’t freak her out.

“You tell me; I’m the one who did surveillance for you barely fifteen minutes ago”, she crossed her arms above her chest, standing her ground.

He glared at her.

“You’re going after the pros”, she stated. “And you shouldn’t do it alone”.

Katsuki scoffed.

“I don’t need your fucking help”.

It was Jirou’s turn to scoff.

“*Seriously*?”

“Yeah, I’m fucking serious”.

“Well, I think you do”.

“What, you’re gonna shove the fact you gave me a hand it in my damn face? No wonder why you like Deku so much”.

She shook her head.

“You’re going to get yourself expelled if you do this alone”.

“No, I’m not”.

“I think you will”.

“And I don’t give a shit what you think”.

“Why do you always have to be so rude? I’m trying to help you and Midoriya!”

“And you’re dumb as fuck, because you can’t get it into your thick skull that the more fucking people I take with me, the higher are the chances we’ll get fucking *caught*, dipshit”, he basically shouted at her face. She flinched in surprise, but didn’t cower beneath his harsh tone. “And I work better alone, anyway, so stay the hell out of this”.

“And what do you plan to do, exactly? Follow All Might and blow the villain up?”, she deadpanned.

“You fucking bet”, he turned his back to her.

“Have you considered, with your *thick skull*”, she continued sarcastically, “that killing the villain could kill Midoriya as well?”

“That’s fucking obvious”, he spat without missing a beat. “I ain’t gonna kill him, just fuck him up”.

Jirou shook her head.

“Don’t you think this would be a lot easier if you had someone who could hear incoming attacks?”

“My ears work just damn fine on their own”.

“Clearly not, since you’re not *listening* to me”, she took a step closer to him. “You’re the one who dragged me to the teachers’ dorm. I’m already *in this*, whether you like it or not. You may not need my help, but you could use it”.

Katsuki looked at her.

“I can’t talk you out of going and possibly getting yourself expelled”, she continued, serious. “But I could help”.

He stared down at her for long moments, as if considering her proposal. Jirou stared back, unfaltering in her determination.

Then Katsuki scoffed, scowling.

“You really want to prove yourself that fucking badly, huh”.

He turned away again.

Jirou swallowed dry and lowered her head, angry and frustrated.

“You’re an asshole, Bakugou”.

He heard her footsteps, and the sound of his bedroom door clicking closed.

Looking back, he found Jirou was gone.

Katsuki was sober.

His mind was rushing at a thousand miles per hour as he paced and paced and paced his bedroom, so lost in deep thought that his furniture and his belongings became invisible to him. All he could see and think about was a plan, a fucking plan that didn’t result in expulsion but that also didn’t result in Deku’s fucking *death*.

He should have seen this coming. He should have fucking stepped up sooner, and now he only had five days.

Five days.

If he had been fucking confused about his feelings before, Katsuki couldn’t describe how he was feeling now. It was the same feeling of sitting on a chair and leaning back too hard, too suddenly – the chair topples back, and your heart immediately rushes in fear of the collision.

All you can feel is the surge of adrenaline and the increasing proximity with the floor as gravity takes its toll.

That was what he was feeling at that precise moment. Adrenaline, making his heart beat fast in his chest. In fear of collision.

Except he *never* felt fear. Which only served to show that, as he was well aware, his emotional range was fucked up beyond reason.

The reason why Katsuki was so good at everything he did was because he was a good planner. He was a good observer, a quick thinker, and a master strategist. He didn't feel fear because he knew he was fucking good, and he was fucking good because he could do all those things without batting an eye. Without doubting himself. Without wasting time wondering about unreasonable what ifs.

He didn't *need* to doubt himself. If there was someone who could fucking save stupid Deku from certain death, that someone was him. No what ifs. No fear of collision.

There would be no fucking collision, because he would save Deku.

Part of himself wanted to convince him that the reason why he wanted to save Deku so badly was to show the nerd how weak and helpless he was, and how superior Katsuki was in comparison. But deep down – despite all the confusing feelings, despite all the mixed emotions, despite everything he still couldn't quite decipher – he knew the real reason why he wanted to save Deku.

He already knew he didn't want Deku to die. What he was having trouble admitting was that he kind of cared about the nerd – he was starting to grow on him, despite of Katsuki's obvious reluctance.

And, in one way or another, Deku had been there with him from day one. His earliest memories had fucking shitty Deku in them – goddamn him –, and Katsuki liked routines. Having Deku removed from his life would break routine. No matter how annoying, he had grown used to the nerd's constant presence – so constant, it had been there from the beginning of his life. Having Deku die and stop being around would be extremely inconvenient. Yes, extremely inconvenient. Therefore, Katsuki had to prevent his death.

This, of course, had nothing to do with the fact that Deku had saved his life, or that Deku had given his life for his, or that Deku wasn't as fucking useless as Katsuki had always assumed him to be.

This had nothing to do with the fact that Deku wasn't a self-entitled asshole as Katsuki had thought his whole life, or that Deku's hug was actually kind of comforting, or that Deku was helping him a lot (even though he would never admit it aloud). This had nothing to do with the fact that he owed Deku his life twice now, or with Deku at all – this only had to do with himself, or so Katsuki tried to think. This only had to do with what he felt, and what he thought, and what he wanted to do, Deku be damned.

He was the best, so he could do this. He was the only person who could save helpless, defenseless Deku from the jaws of death.

There was no reason to be afraid. They were under no risk. Katsuki wouldn't lose – especially not to some random D-lister. Katsuki would fuck that guy up, bring him in, and force him to shove Deku's annoying little soul back into his body. He would put an end to this whole shitshow for once.

Plus, Inko had said that fucking UA itself told her they believed this bastard villain could be decaying at the same pace as Deku's body, so it would be fucking easy to take him down. All Katsuki needed to do was plan things in a way that left no space for defeat – he needed to detach himself from the turmoil that his emotions had become and think rationally, coldly, strategically.

He needed to fucking save Deku.

In the depths of his mind, he reminded himself that he needed to save Deku because there was a chance he would die along with the nerd if he failed, like Jirou had suggested. And Katsuki would be damned if he allowed himself to fucking drop dead just because Deku's shitty, clingy soul dragged him along into the afterlife.

(But he also knew that wasn't the only reason).

He didn't sleep. In fact, he couldn't sleep – his daily training be damned. He couldn't plan shit while he was sleeping, and he needed to plan. He couldn't rush into Hosu and count on fate and luck to be successful, he needed to think straight before taking any action. Despite what other people may think of him, Katsuki wasn't some impulsive bastard who let anger take the best of him and rush him into action. The reason why he was so good – the reason why he was so praised, why he was so admired, why he was on the top – was because he *thought* before he acted. The only occasions in which he had rushed into conclusions without planning ahead were…

Well. So far, they all involved Deku.

But that wouldn't be the fucking case now, because he would be careful.

If anything, he would just accompany the pros' actions from afar and only step in if he saw they were bound to fail. That was the most secure, uneventful plan, and Katsuki would stick to it if he could. He didn't need Ears, or Shitty Hair, or anyone else to offer him backup. He had never needed anyone's help and he wouldn't start needing it now. He could do it alone. He could save Deku alone.

He also didn't want anyone to come crying and whining at his doorstep about being expelled because of him, so there was also that. If he was doing it, he wasn't throwing anyone else under the bus along with him.

Katsuki decided he was better off not thinking about expulsion, since he quickly reached the conclusion that 'saving Deku from certain death' and 'being expelled' were two variables that were *way* too close to each other. But it wasn't like he could just let the damn nerd drop

dead – or let himself be dragged along into death – without doing anything about it, right? If he was careful and stayed in his lane – if he captured the villain alone, without leaving any evidence or proof of his interference – then UA wouldn't be able to expel him. All he had to do was be careful, and not leave any evidence behind.

He would have to tell Deku.

Not only because he had the right to know he might kick the bucket in five days – but because it would be way easier to go in stealthily, capture the villain should UA fail to do so, save Deku's life and go back to the dorms without an anxious, curious-as-fuck nerd yapping on his ear and asking "Where are we going? What are doing here? We shouldn't be here, Kacchan! etc".

Telling Deku wouldn't be easy, but it needed to be done if he wanted to save the nerd's ass without getting kicked out of school in the process.

Katsuki realized that he wouldn't have been able to sleep, not even if he wanted to. Just the thought of looking Deku in the eyes and telling him that he was going to die was enough to keep him awake for an entire night.

(He decided he was also better off not thinking about the nightmares he would probably have if he did fall asleep).

So Katsuki sat by his studying desk, grabbed his notebook, opened it on a blank page, picked up a pen and starting listing what would be the best course of action to help capturing the villain. He also turned his notebook on and google searched for a map of Hosu. He had a long night ahead of him.

He had to stop after a few moments of preparation because of the number of texts that were making his phone vibrate.

From: Shitty Hair

Hey man where u at?

From: Shitty Hair

Everything ok?

From: Raccoon Eyes

You left already? :c

From: Tape Guy

Bakugou get your ass over here we're about to use Mineta as a piñata and you don't wanna miss that

From: Tape Guy

Just kidding we're not doing that I was just trying to make you come down

From: Tape Guy

Just for the record Mina and I wanted to do that but Iida stopped me

From: Shitty Hair

Ahh I wish youd toldm e u were leaving I wantd to say good bye

From: Shitty Hair

Thank u fr o everything really amn

From: Shitty Hair

Man*

From: Shitty Hair

I kno u dont like this kind of sutff to it means sa lot to me that u came

From: Shitty Hair

And cooked hot dogs

From: Shitty Hair

And plaed truth of dare with us….. thank

From: Shitty Hair

You

From: Shitty Hair

Also I still wanna know whta was that stuff with fhe f word so honeslt y Bakugou CALL ME

From: Shitty Hair

Didn't wanna tak about it ifn front of everyone cuz I knew youjd flpi out on my

From: Shitty Hair

Me*

From: Shitty Hair

Anyway love u good nigbt thanks for mcoing gimme a call

Katsuki sighed as he read through the messages. He turned his phone off without responding to any of them, setting the device aside and focusing on what he needed to do.

Izuku opened his eyes, blinking them open sluggishly and lazily while consciousness returned to him.

The first thing he realized was that the angle of the ceiling looked weird. The second thing he realized was that he was sleeping on Kacchan's side of the bed.

The third thing he realized was that Kacchan wasn't on the bed with him, which wasn't unusual – even though Izuku liked to wake up early and stare out the window, Kacchan often got up earlier than him in order to work out and take a shower.

But what was unusual about the situation was that he was lying on Kacchan's side of the bed, there was no pillow fort in the middle, and he was feeling weirdly on edge.

Trying to think back to the events of the previous night, Izuku was embarrassed to find that he could remember little to nothing. The last thing he fully recalled was participating of a truth or dare game with their friends, and everything after that was a confusing blur with a considerable number of gaps. He did have flashes of Kirishima-kun and Kacchan, mostly, but he couldn't even remember getting back to Kacchan's bedroom.

However, he was pleasantly surprised to realize that he was experiencing no usual symptoms of a hangover – no headache, no nausea, no discomfort; just a slight sense of urgency. It was as if he hadn't even drunken anything in the previous night. Izuku didn't know if he should thank the small – and rare – perks of being a temporary ghost, or if this miracle was due to Kacchan's incredible resistance to alcohol – even if it hadn't been *that* much alcohol.

Rubbing the sleep away from his eyes, Izuku turned on his side on the bed, trying to figure out whether Kacchan was still going through his morning workout routine or if he was already in the shower. Much to his surprise, Kacchan was doing neither of those things – he was instead sitting on his rolling chair by his studying desk, staring straight at Izuku. He had no idea how long Kacchan had been staring at him for, but Izuku had to admit that the look in

his eyes was unsettling. It was something between angry, worried, and inexpressive, which didn't really make sense, but didn't give Izuku any peace of mind, either.

He immediately knew something was up.

"O-Oh, hi, good morning, Kacchan", Izuku greeted nervously, sitting up on the bed and giving the boy a nervous smile as he combed his curls away from his eyes with one hand. Katsuki didn't respond – he merely continued to stare at Izuku with that weird, unsettling look.

Izuku blinked up at him, waiting for a response. None came.

"Uh… Did you sleep well?", Izuku asked. Not remembering anything from the night before was starting to make him anxious – had he done something inappropriate? Had he said something inappropriate? Was that why Kacchan was looking at him like… *that*? He tried hard to remember, but he wasn't getting anything out of his muddled mind.

The fact that Kacchan was still not saying anything and was still glaring at Izuku only served to increase his sense of anxiety. What if he did something?!

Instead of replying, Katsuki simply turned back to his desk and sighed heavily, focusing on the computer screen in front of him. His fingers started to tap unrhythmically as he seemed to do his best to look anywhere but at Izuku. Izuku realized he looked troubled – almost as if he was trying to make up his mind about something.

Ok, this was certainly unusual, and it was *really* freaking Izuku out. What was going on? If he had done something, he would rather Kacchan just scream at him about it. Giving him the silent treatment was so unlike the explosive boy that it set off all sorts of red alerts inside of Izuku's brain.

"Is… everything ok?", Izuku tried, nervous. He leaned forwards on the bed, trying to get a better look at Kacchan's face, but it hadn't changed – still conflicted, still angry, still… worried?

He looked tired, Izuku realized. There were dark bags beneath his eyes, and his hair was disheveled… His shoulders were slumped. Izuku frowned.

"Did you sleep at all?", he asked when the sudden realization appeared in his brain, but, as he had predicted, he received no response. Katsuki continued to tap his hand on the desk. The rhythm – or lack of it – was driving Izuku insane. Kacchan had never ignored him before – he would usually tell him to shut up when he wasn't in the mood for talking, or call him names when Izuku angered him. But never put up with his rambling in silence. *Never*.

If Izuku had truly angered him, Kacchan would be screaming, right?

Izuku found a tinge of melancholy poking at his heart as he realized that he was starting to *want* Kacchan to scream at him. It was better than having the boy be so silent.

He tried to reach out for their connection and feel what Kacchan was feeling at that moment, but it was hard. It was usually hard to tell what Kacchan was feeling at all, unless the emotion was strong – and, when it was strong, it was more often than not anger. Usually, the boy's emotions were so mixed up and tangled with one another that it would take Izuku a lot of time and concentration to decipher them. But now, everything was even worse – it was like Kacchan was feeling so much at once that he decided to smother everything down – detach itself from it all. If Izuku had to give his opinion, this didn't feel healthy at all. This, of course, only increased his worry.

"Kacchan", he insisted, well aware of the danger this inflicted upon him. "What's wrong?"

No answer.

"Is it something I did? Did I do something last night?"

Silence.

"I don't remember, so… If I did, I'm sorry".

Katsuki wasn't even looking at him, let alone saying anything.

"It would be helpful if you could tell me what it was, if this is really about something I did. So I don't do it again, you know?"

Silence. Izuku's heartbeat was starting to pick up its pace, because Kacchan's silence was way more terrifying than his anger. He was starting to get really desperate, now.

"Kacchan, I'm worried", he leaned in even closer. "What's going on? Are you ok?"

Still silence. Izuku pursed his lips into a thin line and sighed.

"Are you hungover?"

No response. What if he did something, what if he said something, what if Kacchan hated him now after everything they had gone through and all they had achieved? He was starting to get desperate, and didn't know what else he could recur to in order to make Katsuki talk.

"Would it help if I tried to say your first name? I think I'll probably regret this because you'll definitely mock me forever, but you're being weirdly silent and you're not calling me annoying, so I'm getting really worried right now, *Katchuki* –"

"You're dying".

An awkward pause.

"Uh… W-What?"

Katsuki finally turned his head to look at Izuku, locking eyes with him. He was glaring, but for the first time ever, Izuku didn't think the glare was aimed at him.

“You’re dying”, he repeated in a deadpan, as if that information was nothing. His face looked as stern as Izuku had ever seen it, his crimson eyes turned into angry slits.

Another pause.

“Yeah… I – I know that”.

“No, you fucking *don’t*”.

Silence.

“You don’t know *shit*, shitty Deku. You got fucking wasted last night”.

Izuku blushed slightly.

“Y-Yeah… *That*, I remember”.

“I asked Earphone Girl to help me eavesdrop on All Might”.

A pregnant pause.

“You… *what*?”

“He received a phone call when we were listening. He said some shit about a capture today, at Hosu. He *also* said some shit about the quirk that hit you having a countdown, and that you’re going to die in five days unless they capture the villain”.

Izuku stared at him in silence.

Katsuki stared back. He looked nothing but angry, now, but at least that wasn’t so unsettling. His rage was almost comforting, at this point.

The silence stretched.

“I figured you should know”, Katsuki added as an afterthought after what felt like an eternity, probably due to a lack of things to say, right before he got up from his seat and disappeared into the bathroom.

Izuku stayed where he was, staring blankly at Katsuki’s empty chair.

Oh.

Ok, he hadn’t been expecting that.

He knew he had been dying, but… He hadn’t… He hadn’t really expected it to be…

He lowered his head. His eyes felt unnaturally, uncharacteristically, dry.

He found that he wasn’t exactly sad by the news. He *knew* he had been dying. But he should be panicking, right? He should be crying and sobbing and screaming and getting furious at the universe for making him go through everything he did, for making him struggle so hard

and for so long to earn a quirk and finally gain some acceptance after years of solitude, just to snatch it away in front of him – just to snatch *him* away from life.

But he couldn't feel any of that. All he could think about… All he could think about was his mom.

Oh, god, his *mom*. His mom would be destroyed by his death. He was all that she had; he couldn't just leave her like this. What if she blamed herself? What if she didn't take care of herself? What if she blamed All Might and UA? And oh, god, All Might – All Might would most *definitely* blame himself. For giving Izuku his quirk and putting him into this life, for being helpless and powerless to stop what happened, for not catching the villain in time… And, to make things worse, Izuku realized he never passed One For All on. The ancient quirk that had been trusted to him would fade away along with himself, without a new successor, and they would bury All Might's legacy alongside with his body…

But Kacchan had said something. Yes! He had said there would be a capture today. So there was still hope, right? There was still a chance he wouldn't die? There was still a chance he could be saved?

A sense of determination flooded him. Yes, if the pros were still considering a capture, then that meant there was still hope. And if there was still hope, then Izuku would cling to it with all his might and strength – after all, that was what he had been doing his whole life. There was nothing he excelled at if not at clinging to hope. The hope of becoming a hero, the hope of having a quirk, the hope of meeting All Might, the hope of befriending Kacchan. He had achieved all of those things after years of suffering and struggling – he had no doubt that he could still achieve another small miracle.

Kacchan came out of the bathroom, his hair wet and his UA uniform half-tidied. His shirt was open and his tie was loose around his neck, the only thing in its proper place being his trousers. As soon as Izuku spotted him, he jumped to his feet, giving Katsuki a solemn look. The boy, in return, stared at him with something akin to uninterested surprise.

"So you're not gonna cry your fucking eyes out or some shit like that?", he asked as he buttoned his shirt up in front of the mirror. Izuku pursed his lips into a thin, determined line and tilted his chin slightly upwards.

"No, because I'm not going to die", he stated. Katsuki snorted mockingly through his nose, smirking, but never ceasing to button his shirt with a bored look. It seemed like Izuku would have to convince him, after all.

"Yeah".

"I mean it", he insisted.

"I know. You're not".

Izuku went silent, frankly a bit surprised by the lack of resistance or teasing from the boy. He stared at Katsuki through the mirror with a quizzical look on his face. Katsuki stared back.

“What? You think I’m gonna just fucking sit here and watch your shitty soul fall apart or something? Or worse – do you think I’ll risk getting stuck with your shitty ghost presence for the rest of my life?”

Izuku frowned, suddenly alert. Where was Kacchan trying to get with that?

“*What*? What do you mean?”, he asked, hesitant.

Katsuki resumed buttoning his shirt up and turned to properly look at Izuku at the same time he fastened his tie around his neck, his face as grumpy as ever – but he could see a sense of determination in Kacchan’s eyes that were almost a perfect mirror of his own.

“I mean I’m taking some fucking action, like the damn pros should have done a long fucking time ago”.

Izuku’s frown deepened, and he took a step closer to Katsuki.

“Kacchan”, he said, a serious warning in his tone. “You’re not saying –“

“I’m saying what I’m fucking saying”, he interrupted, turning away from Izuku once again. That was usually an indicator that the conversation was over, but Izuku was not having it. If Kacchan meant what he thought he meant – if he was planning to intervene on this capture mission, to risk himself, to risk losing his hero license *forever* – then Izuku couldn’t allow it.

“And what, exactly, is that?”, Izuku insisted, worried. “What do you mean you’re taking action? What do you plan to do?”

He could see Katsuki rolling his eyes through the mirror.

“The fuck do you think it is?”

“I don’t know”, Izuku said seriously, not breaking eye contact. “And I don’t think I’ll like the answer”.

“Well, lucky for you, I don’t give a *shit* what you like or not”.

“*Kacchan*”, Izuku took another step towards him, his tone serious.

Katsuki turned on his heels in order to face him once again, a mixture of emotions flashing across his mostly angry crimson eyes. Izuku found himself lost in them, desperate to find meaning in that gaze but encountering nothing but burning, scorching determination.

“I’m going after the fucking pros”, he said simply, sounding almost as if he was daring Izuku to contradict him. Their eyes never turned away from one another.

“*Why*?”, Izuku frowned, shaking his head slightly.

He couldn’t understand it for the life of him. Kacchan had turned away from Todoroki’s plan because he had deemed Izuku not worth the trouble, and now not only had he eavesdropped

on All Might, but he was also willing to risk his *license* for him? What could have possibly caused this sudden change in opinion and behavior?

Katsuki, however, seemed offended and confused by that question, the intensity of the rage inside his eyes increasing.

The truth was – not even Katsuki knew *why*. So now he kind of gave a shit about the nerd and didn't fancy the thought of him dying. So fucking what? That still wasn't enough to risk his license and his career over. That wasn't fucking enough – that wasn't worth it.

Then why couldn't he stand the thought of sitting idly and doing nothing as Izuku's life got shorter and shorter with each ticking of his clock?

"Because that bunch of assholes have shown nothing but incompetence in dealing with this shitshow", Katsuki said, walking past Izuku in order to grab his shoes. He sat at the edge of his bed and started to put his socks on, not looking at the boy anymore. "If they knew what they're doing, they would have caught the bastard already".

"And you think you can help them?", Izuku asked with incredulity. Katsuki immediately snapped his head up in order to give him a death glare.

"You underestimating me, nerd?", he asked in a threatening, low tone. Izuku raised his hands as if he was trying to calm a wild animal.

"No", he tried to say. "That wasn't what I meant –"

"Then what did you fucking mean? Huh?", Katsuki got to his feet, walking towards Izuku with his nostrils flaring in anger. The sight would have been more frightening if Katsuki had managed to put both his socks on before he stood up. "Because to me, it sounds like you don't think I'm fucking capable of taking this asshole down".

"That's not what I think at all and you know it", Izuku said defensively, managing to stand unfaltering even under such a threatening display. "I'm just saying that you shouldn't go".

"And who the fuck do you think you are to tell me what to do?", he asked in a low voice, dangerously close to Izuku.

"Kacchan", Izuku said reasonably, "You could *lose your license*".

"Only if I get caught".

A pause. Izuku squinted.

"And how do you plan on capturing the villain without the heroes realizing you're there?"

Katsuki snorted, victorious, as if Izuku had just handed him the space to offer an unambiguous argumentation.

"From what All Might said, *and* from Eraser Head's presence, it's safe to assume this capture mission will be a stealth one. Which means that it will be an *ambush*, dipshit".

“So?”, Izuku shrugged.

“So all I gotta do is wait until the asshole who glued you to me is alone, kick his fucking ass, and leave him where the heroes can find him”, he sat back down in order to put his other sock on.

“What if he’s not alone? Huh?”, Izuku pointed out. “What if he has backup? Other villains who can hurt you?”

Katsuki growled again. Izuku continued before the boy could complain about his lack of faith.

“I’m not saying they’re *better* than you, I’m just saying –“, he sighed. “It’s too risky”.

“I like risky”.

“You should leave it to the pros”.

“And you should shut the fuck up, but there you fucking are”.

“I’m *serious*, Kacchan. I don’t want you to risk your future license –“

“ – There is *no* fucking risk –“

“ – and blame me for it afterwards! You should just stay back here and let the pros handle this”.

“Oh, yeah, because they’ve been handling it so *well* recently, hiding shit from the people involved, hiding shit from your *mom*, going on capture missions that fucking failed and leaving your fucking body to die alone without even telling anyone about it”.

Izuku stared at him for a few moments as Katsuki fastened his shoes.

“Where did this come from?”

Katsuki lifted his head to look at him, an unreadable look on his face. Upon his silence, Izuku continued.

“I just don’t get it, Kacchan. One day, you hate me. The other day, we’re stuck together, and we seem to be building something, something better than we had before, and then you have these moments where it feels like you’ve gone all the way back to hating me again. Then one day we’re hugging, and on the next you can barely stand to look at me”.

Katsuki continued to stare at him, his anger increasing.

“I just don’t know what you want from me. I don’t know what you’re thinking”, Izuku admitted, overtaken by the heat of the discussion. Katsuki’s red eyes felt like they were burning holes in him. “I don’t know what you want me to do”, he added in a quieter voice.

Katsuki stood up, both feet in his shoes this time, and walked over to Izuku with a threatening pose. His eyes – his eyes were constantly furious, now.

"I want you to shut the fuck up and not second guess me", he growled. Then, he bent down and grabbed his backpack, ready to leave for class.

Izuku stared at him for a few silent moments before shaking his head. His eyes were finally getting moist, now.

"*No*", he protested, firm, even though his voice was starting to give off that ugly wobble that he hated so much. "I won't let you do this".

Katsuki smiled a humorless smile, as if smiling was the only thing he could do on that moment in order to prevent himself from tackling Deku to the ground and murdering him on the spot. He took in a deep breath and turned to the boy with an ugly, vicious, angry scowl on his face, his backpack thrown over his shoulder.

"You can do us all a favor and shove that self-sacrificial *bullshit* you love to pull so much right back up your petulant fucking ass".

Izuku snorted, indignant.

"Oh, *I'm* petulant?"

"Yes, you fucking *are*".

"You're the one who thinks it's such a great idea to follow the pro heroes on the manhunt of a guy who could have very well gotten you killed! How am *I* the petulant one?"

Katsuki fumed.

"That's rich, coming from the guy who did exactly *the same fucking thing* when the League captured me".

Izuku's face paled.

"What, you think I don't know that was your shitty fucking plan? As if any of those bastards would be stupid enough to pull that reckless crap out".

Izuku's face scrunched up with a determined frown.

"That was different".

"No, it fucking wasn't. It was the same, except, unlike you, I'm not fucking stupid enough to involve other people in this".

"First of all, I didn't involve anyone – Kirishima-kun did. He was the one who came after me in the hospital, and gathered everyone up –"

"Because he's fucking stupid".

“Would you *stop that*?!”

“Fuck, no. If you can’t deal with the truth, that ain’t my problem. But no matter what fucked up excuse your tiny brain tries to come up with, I’m still going to do this”.

“What I’m trying to tell you is that the League situation was different!”

Katsuki turned to him with an angry, impatient glare.

“You risked your fucking license coming after me, didn’t you?”

Izuku stared up at him, silent. Katsuki scoffed.

“There. You got your payback, now”.

“I don’t want any payback, Kacchan”, Izuku shook his head. “I didn’t do it for a reward”.

“I don’t care what you did it for”.

“At least take some backup with you! It’s much safer than going alone!”

“I don’t need anyone to back me up. I can fucking do this”.

“I don’t think –“

“I don’t give a shit, shitty Deku! I ain’t about to be taken down by a fucking D-lister, so shut the hell up and stop trying to convince me!”

Izuku shook his head at him again.

“He could have killed you last time”.

“I wouldn’t have *gotten fucking killed*”, Katsuki snarled.

“No, because I got in the way! And I can’t do it again this time!”

“I don’t fucking need you to save me, you piece of shit”, he growled.

“And you don’t need to risk your hero career over me, either!”

“What the *fuck* is it with you; do you actually want to fucking die?”, he pushed Izuku away. “Do you want me to let these bastards get you killed? Because trust me, shitty Deku, you’re *really fucking close* to convincing me I should just *let* you drop dead”.

“Well, that would be easier to understand than *this*!”

Katsuki halted.

Izuku stared at him, panting. He stared back.

Was that what Deku thought? That Katsuki wishing his death was easier to comprehend than Katsuki wanting to save his life?

Was that what Deku thought of him? What Deku expected of him?

What Deku wanted of him?

Katsuki knew he'd been an asshole to Izuku, but he had already told him that, despite whatever shit he might have said or done in the past, he had never actually wanted Deku to die. And despite all his improvement, despite everything he was doing to control his anger and be a better person, Izuku still thought it would be more natural for Katsuki to want him dead.

For Katsuki to let him die.

If *this* was the image Deku upheld of a hero… Then Katsuki didn't know what kind of hero Deku was admiring.

All he knew was that, for some messed up, incomprehensible reason, Deku's words – Deku's assumption – had hurt him. They had been a low fucking blow. There he was, like a fucking idiot, trying to save the asshole's life, trying to risk his career for the bastard – and shitty Deku still expected Katsuki to be the type of person who would let him die. That made Katsuki's primordial, ancient, animalistic instinct desire to hurt him back in retaliation.

"You really wanna know why the fuck I wanna go after the pros and make sure they get to save your stupid ass?", he growled, angry, frenzied, vengeful. Izuku stared at him in silence. "Because I don't give a shit if you have a death wish or an attention kink – I ain't gonna be dragged down with you because of it".

Izuku blinked at him, a flash of hurt confusion coursing through his eyes. Katsuki breathed out.

This wasn't as satisfactory as he had expected.

"W-What?", Izuku asked, nervous. Katsuki scowled at him.

"I don't wanna risk having my soul dragged along with yours if you die", he continued, remembering Jirou's accusation, remembering his own flash of fear at that newfound possibility that he, the stupid ass he was, hadn't even considered in the first place.

Izuku's face paled. From the look of it, he hadn't considered that possibility either.

"Nothing to say to that, huh?", Katsuki teased, even though his triumph tasted bitter. Izuku seemed unable to meet his eyes anymore – they had turned downwards in an almost shameful way. "Did I finally shut your damn mouth, nerd?"

Izuku didn't say anything. His curls were hiding his eyes away from view.

Katsuki stayed there, standing in the middle of his bedroom with his backpack on and lacking the urge to move. Izuku's shoulders began to rattle softly, as if…

Oh, fucking *great*. Was the nerd fucking crying now? Katsuki had wanted to hurt him for hurting *him*, but fuck if he would guess that *this* shit would be what it took to make the nerd cry. Hearing that he was going to die in five days? A-OK. Hearing that he might cause Katsuki's death as a result? Arma-fucking-geddon.

Deku's mom was right. The asshole was fucking *hopeless*.

"Quit fucking crying", Katsuki said, because he didn't know what else – or how else – to say it. This only served to increase the rattling of Deku's shoulders, and soon enough he was openly sobbing.

"I'm sorry, Kacchan", he apologized, and fuck if Katsuki knew what to do. He had honestly not expected this outcome – nor desired it. His anger seemed to dissipate a bit at the sight of a crying Deku – which was an irony, because, if a month before, he had seen Deku cry because of something he said, Katsuki would have been fucking annoyed. "I'm sorry. I didn't know – I didn't, I had no idea, I'm sorry. I don't want to get you killed, that's – that's the very thing I was trying to stop, oh god, I'm sorry, I'm so sorry", he sobbed freely, covering his eyes with his hands.

Katsuki sighed, allowing his shoulders to slump and rolling his eyes. *Really*?

"Look, Deku. I'm not a fucking fan of the idea of going all the way to fucking Hosu and risking my hero license either, but it's not like we have many options, here. All Might mentioned other capture missions that failed. If this one fails too, you'll probably kick the bucket. They'll definitely have better chances to catch this fucking guy if I'm there".

Izuku looked up at him, eyes shiny and moist and tear tracks running down his freckled cheeks. Katsuki ignored the way the sight made his heart leap.

"You're the one who keeps fucking telling me all about how amazing I am", he continued. This, for some reason, earned a nervous smile from Izuku, who tried his best to wipe his tears away from his face.

"B-Because you a-are", he said, voice thick with emotion. Katsuki eyerolled again.

"Then don't fucking question me about this. I'm not diving headfirst into this shit without thinking about a plan, or about the consequences. I ain't *you*", he added. Izuku didn't seem offended by this. "I know what I'm fucking doing".

Izuku stared at him for long moments that felt like an eternity, looking like he was trying to make up his mind – as if he would have any means of stopping a determined, stubborn Katsuki.

"I – I trust you, Kacchan", Izuku said eventually, serious. His eyes were still wet, but the tear flow had stopped. "I trust you with my life".

Katsuki simply glared at him, nodding. That was settled, then.

"Good. Now let's fucking go before we get any later to class".

He turned on his heels and reached for the door handle, ready to leave the bedroom. He had a long day ahead of him – he hadn’t slept a wink during the previous night, and now he would have to sit through hours of classes and social interaction before he could finally sneak his way out of the school and find a way to Hosu.

Despite this, no doubt crossed his mind – he knew that he would be able to defeat the villain, and he would most probably find a way to do so without giving his teachers any physical evidence that could justify an expulsion. Maybe he could even ask Kirishima to make him an alibi, once he had gotten far away enough in order for his best friend to chase after him.

Izuku followed him out silently, head still bowed and tear tracks still covering his cheeks. Katsuki decided he was better off not looking at him, or even thinking about him at all – his plans always worked better without emotional attachment.

Chapter End Notes

Honestly, this one... Oh, this one. Things are getting tense, right.
Gotta admit I was a bit nervous about writing my best girl Jirou, but I really love her and I wanted to have her in this story (even if I didn't really nail her character... hmm).
Anyway. You know the saying. When you're at the bottom of the well, there's nowhere to go but up, right? Unless you have a shovel and can dig yourself even deeper down.
You know the drill. Updates aren't quite so regular anymore because of work, uni, life in general etc. I'm trying my best here, guys. Hope you enjoyed this, though!
See you next time around ;-)

Chapter 14: Exit Music For a Film

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

He was on his knees, staring at his own hands with wide, fixed eyes that searched desperately for something that wasn't there.

His ears were still ringing from the explosions he had produced himself. The feeling wasn't uncommon – whenever he pushed himself too far or recurred to attacks such as the howitzer, it would take some time for his ears to get back to normal. He had never told anyone, but he thought he was starting to get tinnitus. Sometimes, the ringing in his ears was too constant or too loud for him not to worry – but he would rather lose his hearing than to stop using his quirk.

A large hand grabbed his shoulder and he startled, not having heard or sensed any movement from behind him in his shock. His immediate response was to aim an explosion at whoever was grabbing him, which he did, but it had no effect – All Might, however quirkless he was now, was still strong enough to endure one of Katsuki's weak attacks. He had used up all of his sweat by now. Whatever explosions he could produce at this point, after pushing himself to his limit, would be too weak to harm even a child.

His hands hurt. His shoulders ached. His back ached. His chest and his ribs ached, even though he had received no sort of blow in those particular places.

He couldn't breathe, suddenly. And as All Might stared down at him with questioning eyes, searching eyes, eyes that were begging for some sort of answer or confirmation, all Katsuki could do was swallow an ugly sob that was threatening to rise to his throat and scrunch his face up in an ugly grimace, fighting back the tears that were already pooling in his crimson, ever angry eyes.

He hated crying. He rarely ever cried. And whenever he did, it was due to strong, alien emotion. Defeat, for when Deku beat him in the training exercise. Guilt, for when he caused the end of a person he admired and loved, such as All Might.

Right at that moment, Katsuki was feeling both things. Defeat and guilt, throbbing inside his heart like a painful reminder of his failure and his loss.

All Might pulled his limp, silently sobbing form into a tight hug. Katsuki could tell he was crying, too, and found that there was nothing, absolutely nothing he could say.

They arrived at the classroom before anyone else, as usual, which only made everything worse.

As Katsuki took his seat and opened his notebook in front of him, Izuku sitting behind him, he reviewed every step of the plan he had spent the entire night carefully thinking about, trying not to dwell on the fact that Izuku was uncharacteristically silent. His own eyes were heavy and blurry from tiredness, but he figured he could take a power nap once he was done with the afternoon classes and before the time came when he had to leave.

The first person to arrive around ten minutes after he did was Todoroki, who looked as stoic and uninterested as ever. Katsuki spared him a simple, quick glance when he heard the classroom door opening, but averted his gaze away from the bastard as soon as he realized who it was. He didn't have any time to waste on Icy Hot, or the patience to deal with him. He could feel Izuku staring up at the boy, but he remained silent.

Several minutes passed in silence before Izuku spoke up, the first time he did so ever since they left Katsuki's bedroom.

"Do you think I should…?", and then he trailed off with a sight before finishing his thought.

Katsuki rolled his eyes and leaned back on his chair so that Deku's head would be closer to his. As much as he hated the idea of talking to someone invisible in front of Icy Hot, he decided he didn't give a shit – at least this way, he could remind the Half'n'Half bastard that he could see Izuku when he couldn't; he could touch Izuku when he couldn't; he could talk to Izuku when he couldn't.

"What?", he asked sharply, impatience evident in his voice. Izuku sighed and hesitated.

"It's nothing. We won't be able to do it anyway".

Katsuki eyerolled again.

"Stop playing hard to get and spit it the fuck out already".

A pause. Katsuki could feel Todoroki's gaze glued on him from where he sat far behind him.

"I wanted to say goodbye", Izuku explained in a low voice. "To… Well. Todoroki-kun, and Uraraka-san, and Iida-kun, my friends... Just in case, you know? But I know we can't do it".

Katsuki was silent for a moment. If he went around telling Deku's friends that Deku loved them and all the shit, he was bound to raise some eyebrows – and definitely some suspicion. It was bad enough that Earphone Girl knew about his plan – they didn't need anyone else trying to intervene. Or worse – telling a teacher about it.

"We can't do it", Katsuki said, even though he knew Deku was aware.

“Yeah”, was the boy’s melancholic response.

Silence. When it became clear that Izuku wasn’t speaking up again, Katsuki leaned forwards on his seat once more and went back to reviewing his plan.

He could still feel Todoroki’s eyes on him, but was too tired to make a big deal about it.

More students arrived after that – Iida and Uraraka being the first ones after Todoroki. Katsuki paid them no attention, even if most of them stared at him for several moments as they entered the room. He had more important things to think about.

Earphone Girl was the one who stared at him the hardest. Katsuki pretended not to see her, and continued to go over his plan again and again.

Kirishima was the first person to talk to him, rather than just stare at him, once he arrived at the classroom. Trailing behind him were Kaminari and Sero, the former looking like death warmed over and the latter looking just slightly tired. Katsuki stared up at the three friends standing in front of his table, said nothing, and went back to his notebook.

“Hey, man”, Kirishima greeted when Katsuki did nothing to acknowledge his presence there. “How are you feeling?”

Katsuki gritted his teeth. Kirishima’s pointless chatter was something he could barely put up with at the best of days – now, as he stood on the doors of the apocalypse, it was the last thing he needed.

“Fine”, he said with a growl, making sure to make his tone sound as dismissive as humanly possible. Kirishima didn’t take the hint.

“Sleep well?”

“The fuck do you think?”, Katsuki growled again, not looking up.

“I think *not*, dude”, he chuckled, followed by Sero. “You’re looking worse than Denki, and he drank like, five times more than you”.

“Lie”, Kaminari protested, but his voice was hoarse and his tone was low.

“I’m fine”, Katsuki repeated, annoyed. “Just busy”.

“Huh”, was Kirishima’s response, since he knew better than to try and take a look at whatever was keeping Katsuki busy – which, in this case, was his notebook.

Kirishima kept staring down at his best friend, waiting for some sort of continuation to the conversation, but none came. When Katsuki remained silent, Kirishima awkwardly scratched the back of his neck, unsure how to approach the subject that was clearly bothering him ever since he had arrived.

“Uhh… Why are you wearing a tie, man?”

Katsuki's teeth were grinding so hard that his jaw felt about to snap. He couldn't do one single fucking thing differently without people wanting to shove their fucking noses into his fucking life? He had to fucking remain static for his entire fucking life? Was that what fucking Kirishima wanted? What was so fucking wrong about him wearing his tie anyway?

"I was wondering about that, too", Deku mumbled quietly from his seat. Katsuki fumed.

He hadn't even put much thought into it when he put it on that morning. Fine, ok, he rarely used a tie, but him putting one on wasn't such a big deal. It shouldn't be a big fucking deal.

That was why he never did shit differently. Whenever he bothered, people kept shoving it on his fucking face.

His mood was already fucked up from everything that was happening – his discovery from the night prior, the weight of the night that was coming… Shitty Deku's mope-y mood wasn't doing wonders for his temper, either. He didn't have the patience to deal with Kirishima's meddling on the top of everything, and, even though he knew that his actions could be interpreted as an explosive overreaction by anyone who didn't know about the shitshow that was going on in his life, he couldn't quite bring himself to care about that.

He angrily yanked his tie away from his neck and threw it at Kirishima's confused form, glaring up at his best friend with a look that Kirishima knew very well – a look that told him to not mess with Katsuki while he was in such a bad mood.

"Fucking happy now?", Katsuki growled with fury.

Kirishima blinked blankly, holding the tie in one hand and a plastic bag that Katsuki only now noticed on the other. He stared down at Katsuki for a few moments, as if trying to figure out what could have possibly happened to make him that grumpier than usual.

"Well, since you're in such a sour mood", he said, shoving Katsuki's tie beneath his armpit as if it was now his and removing the contents from inside his plastic bag. "I brought you something. As you left the party so early"

Katsuki snorted through his nose, still glaring up at Kirishima.

"I didn't leave early".

"I saved you a piece", Kirishima ignored him and continued, offering him a plastic pot.

Katsuki simply stared – or rather glared – at his friend, and didn't take the pot from his hands.

"It's cake, man", Kirishima explained, trying to hand Katsuki the pot as if the reason why he hadn't taken it was because he didn't know what it was. "You left before we sung happy birthday, so I thought you'd like a piece. Sato didn't know it when he cooked it, but it's your favorite flavor".

Katsuki continued to glare at him.

Kirishima looked slightly hurt by that, still holding out the pot for him to take.

Katsuki rolled his eyes and grabbed the plastic pot from Kirishima's hand more aggressively than he needed to. Kirishima smiled softly, thankful that his best friend hadn't rejected him.

"Someone's grumpy", Sero commented in a low voice, with a smirk and raised eyebrows painting his face. It was clear that he hadn't meant for Katsuki to hear the words, but he obviously failed.

"If I were you, I'd wipe that fucking smile off your face before someone kicks your teeth in", Katsuki squinted his eyes at him. Sero immediately put up his hands in front of his chest in a peace gesture.

"Well, anyway", Kirishima said, placing one hand on Katsuki's shoulder and squeezing it friendly. *Too much physical contact*. "Thanks for staying yesterday, man, even if you left early".

"I didn't fucking leave early", Katsuki repeated himself, because honestly, Kirishima should be glad he had even stayed for as long as he did.

"You did miss the Mineta-piñata we did when Iida wasn't looking", Sero commented from behind Kirishima's shoulder. "That was like, a *crucial* part of the party. If you left before that, then you left early".

"I don't need a party as an excuse to turn that asshole into a piñata", was Katsuki's unbothered response, which drew a laugh from both Kirishima and Sero. Kaminari, on the other hand, flinched at the loud noise and covered his ears.

"I'm going to my seat", he announced with a croak. There were heavy bags under his eyes. "You guys are too loud".

"Also, man", Kirishima continued as Kaminari turned on his heels and all but plopped down on his seat. Katsuki shrugged his friend's hand off his shoulder and Kirishima complied, breaking the touch without hesitating. "You really didn't need to go that hard with my present", he commented with a chuckle. Katsuki turned his head in order to glare at him again.

"I thought you'd like that shit. You never shut up about the fucking Crimson Riot", was his grumpy response. Kirishima immediately shook his head.

"No, no, no, dude, it's not that!", he explained. "I *loved* it. It was really amazing!"

"Then why the fuck are you complaining about it?", Katsuki scoffed.

"I'm not *complaining*", Kirishima sighed. "It's just that… It must have been expensive, right?", he gave Katsuki an almost embarrassed smile. "It was official merch, and I know how much those cost".

"So what?", Katsuki deadpanned.

“So you shouldn’t have!”, Kirishima said, awkward. “I don’t know how to repay you”.

“You don’t have to fucking repay me, it was your damn birthday”, Katsuki rolled his eyes, turning back to his notebook. “If you didn’t like it, throw it in the garbage or something”.

“Bakugou, I *loved* it!”, Kirishima exclaimed in protest.

“He really did”, Sero confirmed. “When we opened the presents, yours was the only one that made him cry”.

“They were manly tears, ok?!”, Kirishima protested.

“Yeah, sure man”, Sero chuckled.

“If he was fucking crying, maybe it’s because the rest of the presents *sucked*”, Katsuki gave Sero a pointed, shit-eating smirk. Then, before Kirishima could protest and reprehend Katsuki for making such accusations, he turned to his best friend. “What did Fuckface and No-Brains give you?”

Kirishima hesitated.

“Uh, Sero gave me a really nice Crimson Riot shirt and Kaminari gave me a Crimson Riot backpack”.

“So y’all just copied my fucking idea and went to the Crimson Riot store?”, Katsuki gave Sero a glare.

“Hey, it’s not my fault he’s a Crimson Riot fan!”, he protested.

“I really am”, Kirishima nodded. “*And* I loved all the presents. Every one of them, ok?”, he emphasized, still bothered by Katsuki’s previous statement.

“If you loved it then don’t fucking come around complaining about it”, Katsuki huffed, turning to his notebook once again.

“I wasn’t –“

“That’s just his Kiri way of saying thank you, Bakubro”, Sero stepped in, throwing an arm around Kirishima’s shoulders. Kirishima smiled at Katsuki.

“Yeah. Thanks, man. I – I really loved your present”, he said. Katsuki glared up at him, stared at his ridiculous happy face for a while and simply nodded in response, going back to his notebook.

Kirishima was nice. Way too fucking sentimental for Katsuki’s liking (even though no one could top Deku on that), but nice anyway. He was a good friend. And he was one of the only people who knew how to deal with Katsuki’s bullshit without pissing the fuck out of him, so there was also that.

He still didn't know what Kirishima wanted him to say in response to all that. The present wasn't such a big deal. Going to his party wasn't such a big deal. They were fucking friends; Katsuki hated this birthday bullshit, but they were still friends. He was supposed to fucking go, right? Did Kirishima really think Katsuki wouldn't show up to his fucking birthday party?

He decided silence was the best thing to do when he didn't know what to say.

(Also, nothing seemed like a big deal anymore in the face of what he had discovered on the night prior).

"But anyway", Kirishima continued when Katsuki didn't say anything else. "Are we grabbing lunch together later? I still want you to tell me about –"

Before he could continue (*and thank fuck he was interrupted*, Katsuki thought), Aizawa sensei entered the room with dark bags beneath his tired eyes and his usual bored expression. The entirety of 1-A went silent immediately. The teacher didn't have to say a word for Kirishima and Sero, along with some other students who were still standing up, to find their way to their seats and settle down. Kirishima gave Katsuki one last smile before heading to his seat.

Aizawa sensei started the morning class without further ado, and his (mostly) hungover, tired students did their best to keep up. If their teacher had any idea that they had stayed up late partying in the night before, he gave no indication.

Katsuki took notes of what he said throughout the lecture and answered the questions the teacher directed at him, sometimes staring deep into Aizawa sensei's eyes as he spoke – whether searching for something in his sensei's eyes or hoping that his sensei found something in his, he didn't know.

(If he averted his gaze away, the teacher could realize he was up to something. But looking into Katsuki's angry, righteous eyes, he was sure the teacher was bound to figure something out, too.)

Katsuki felt betrayed. Most of all, he felt angry – a sort of anger that not even his soulbond with Deku could even out. An anger that spread through him, that took him over, that demanded justice. Aizawa sensei knew Deku was dying, he knew Deku was dying in five fucking days, and there he was. Teaching his class, as if there was nothing wrong. Talking shit about quirk theory, when one of his damn students was about to lose his life in less than a week.

What fucking kind of heroes were they? What was the point of sitting through hours of their shitty lectures when there was someone dying and they kept it a secret?

Katsuki had always wanted to be a hero. He could fucking admit now that his idea of what a hero was had been fucking misplaced for most of his life, but after he was accepted into UA, after he got to know all of those bastards on his class, after he was saved by shitty Deku against his will – after Deku fucking threw his life on the line in order to save him… He knew, now. He knew what kind of hero he wanted to be. He knew what kind of hero he *would* become.

It was nothing that could be taught to him in a lecture. It was nothing that could be taught to him in a training. It was something that took him years to learn, years to absorb, years to understand, despite all his reluctance, all his rage, all his self-righteousness.

He would be a hero that saved people.

He had spent years bullying Deku, and abusing him, and putting him down. He had gone as far as telling the nerd to kill himself. And, despite all that, Deku had still come for him, quirkless and defenseless, when Katsuki had been captured by the sludge villain. Despite all that, Deku had still placed himself between Katsuki and the villain's blow that was meant for him.

The deepest, most primordial part of his brain hated himself for having that tiny scrap of admiration for Deku, of all people, but Katsuki fucking knew better, now. Deku was annoying, and irritating, and loud, and sentimental, and weak, and he pissed the hell out of Katsuki on his best days. But, as much as it pained him, Katsuki couldn't keep denying that the bastard was *persistent*. He was fucking brave. Reckless, and stupid, but also fucking brave. And, most of all, Deku was *selfless*. Unhealthily so, yes, but selfless still.

Maybe he could take the best parts of Deku and try to absorb them into himself.

He could use some selflessness. That was a part of being a good hero, right?

And that was what he would do. Finally pay Deku by saving his ass for a change. Act selfless for once. Be a hero. A proper hero – a hero that Deku would finally have good reason to admire and look up to.

Having shitty Deku glued to him for almost a month had taught him more about heroism than almost a whole damn schoolyear.

Katsuki fucking hated it, but it was the truth. If he ever wanted to improve, he would have to start facing the truth, rather than pretending it wasn't there.

There were many things he would have to start to face, if he was to follow that idea. But he had to learn how to walk before he could run.

Once the class was dismissed, Katsuki stood up and walked out unceremoniously, without waiting for his friends, without acknowledging Kirishima's calls of his name. He could feel Aizawa sensei's eyes glued to him as he passed in front of his desk, but ignored it completely.

Izuku had been silent the entire morning, not having asked one single question about the lecture or made a single comment about Katsuki's conversation with his friends except for that one about the tie. Katsuki would have almost forgotten the nerd was even glued to him at all, if he could only find a way to stop thinking about Deku in the first place.

He was leaving the dining hall when All Might appeared in front of him.

“Young Bakugou”, he called.

Katsuki walked past him with his head bowed and his hands shoved into his pockets, not looking at his sensei or even acknowledging his presence. He could feel a twist in his chest and knew the feeling was coming from Deku, but kept walking.

He didn’t want to talk to All Might. All Might knew Deku was fucking dying and told them nothing.

Plus, the faint possibility that All Might would finally reveal the truth about Deku’s condition would ruin his fucking plan. Because if he told Katsuki, he would most certainly tell him to stay at UA and not intervene in the capture mission. And, if All fucking Might told him not to go to Hosu and he went anyway, he would be disobeying direct orders – which meant certain expulsion. On the other hand, if Katsuki went to Hosu while the teachers thought he didn’t know about the capture mission, things would be a lot less risky – even if they *did* find evidence of his presence there, they wouldn’t be able to prove it was him for sure. After all, if Katsuki didn’t know about Deku’s condition and the capture mission, he would have no reason to go to Hosu, right?

So yeah. No talking to All Might. He couldn’t risk officially knowing about Deku, or he wouldn’t be able to do anything without signing his own early retirement from the hero business.

“Young Bakugou”, All Might called again as Katsuki walked away.

He didn’t stop walking.

“Kacchan”, Izuku said, the first time he spoke up ever since the morning class. For some reason, that pissed Katsuki off.

They were hours away from settling their fate, he had spent the entire fucking morning as tense as a violin bow, he was about to fucking *snap*, and all fucking shitty Deku did was follow him around with a blank face and nothing to offer him but silence. *Now* he wanted to speak the fuck up? To convince him to talk to All Might and ruin the fucking plan, of all things?

“So now you want to fucking talk?”, Katsuki couldn’t help but to mutter angrily.

“What?”, Izuku asked, frowning in clear confusion.

“You spent the whole fucking morning with nothing to say, and you decide to speak the fuck up now?”, he scoffed.

Izuku stared at him.

“Kacchan”, he said, and his voice sounded more tired than Katsuki had ever heard it. “Can we please not do this?”

Katsuki continued to stare straight ahead, still walking away from All Might along the corridor.

“Not today”, Izuku added upon Katsuki’s silence, his voice heavy. “Please”.

Katsuki’s only response was a sight and prolonged silence.

All Might, of course, didn’t let him go so easily. Before Katsuki managed to turn on the corridor and head out of the building, a large hand touched his shoulder, making him stop on his tracks. He didn’t look at the taller man or even turned to face him, keeping his back turned to the number one hero instead.

“Young Bakugou”, All Might repeated for the third time. He sounded… Katsuki didn’t know the word. But he sounded wrong.

(He didn’t sound like the strong, fearless hero Katsuki had spent his whole life admiring.)

“Can we talk?”

Katsuki scoffed. *Really*? He had the whole fucking month to talk, but chose to wait until there were only five days left in order to tell Katsuki that Deku was dying? Because of *him*?

“About what?”, Katsuki responded in a grim, angry voice. Anyone who knew him would define his tone as grumpy, but All Might must have known better. He *must* have known where Katsuki’s anger was coming from.

All Might retrieved his hand from Katsuki’s shoulder, but stayed where he was.

“About… Young Midoriya”, he responded after swallowing dry.

Katsuki scoffed and smirked, shaking his head with disdain.

“Got nothing to talk about”, Katsuki responded, going back to walking. Before he could get too far, All Might stopped him by gently holding his wrist, which Katsuki quickly removed from the man’s grasp.

“Kacchan…”, Izuku tried again, clearly not knowing how to ask for Katsuki to stop and listen to the symbol of peace. Katsuki pointed the boy with a warning glare.

“There is… something I believe you and Young Midoriya should know”, All Might continued, and that was what finally made Katsuki turn to face the man for the first time that day, allowing all the anger and betrayal he was feeling to show on his eyes.

They stared at each other for a tense moment.

“Have you told his mom?”

All Might stared at him; so did Izuku.

“Pardon me?”, was All Might’s confused response.

“His mom”, Katsuki scoffed. “Whatever it is you want to tell me so badly; have you told her first?”, he demanded. He couldn’t remember ever glaring so hard at someone before. Because All Might knew. All Might had known all along, and he said nothing.

He let Inko Midoriya lose her sleep and her appetite for days over the mysteries surrounding her son, instead of just fucking telling her about what was really going on. And yeah, Katsuki could understand, if he tried really hard, that All Might and Aizawa sensei and Recovery Girl and every single one of those bastards had probably kept everything a secret because of Principal Nezu’s orders, but fucking *still*. They were pro heroes, *grown ass* heroes; they should have fucking known better.

All Might looked slightly taken aback by Katsuki’s question, but after a few seconds nodded his head solemnly.

“I told Mrs. Midoriya this morning”, he said. “And I saw it fit to tell you now, as well”.

Katsuki glared up at him. He wondered if All Might would even tell him the whole truth, or if he would make up some sort of shitty excuse for Katsuki to buy, just to remove the guilt from his own shoulders. The guilt of not telling anyone until it was almost too late, the guilt of keeping such a vital piece of information a secret for so long.

He didn’t look like he had any idea Katsuki had heard his conversation on the previous night, though. And if All Might didn’t know, he had no reason to tell Katsuki everything – he could just make up half-truths and shove them down his throat, trusting his student to be none the wiser.

It was a bit sad how Katsuki felt like he couldn’t trust his school anymore.

He glared up at All Might again.

“I don’t want to know”, he said, the look in his eyes daring All Might to contradict him. The symbol of peace looked slightly surprised.

“You… don’t?”

“No”, Katsuki spat. His hands were tightened into fists. “If you could spend so long without telling me anything, then I think you can wait a little longer. It’s not like we’re in a rush, right?”

All Might stared at him.

Katsuki stared back.

Izuku’s gaze was shifting between the two men he admired the most.

“You’re the one who told me that no information about Deku’s state could leak out, or he’d be screwed”, Katsuki added after a few seconds of tense silence. “Principal’s orders. *Right*?”

All he could remember was Icy Hot breaking into his fucking room and telling him about his plan to eavesdrop on a board meeting. *They’re aware, better than anyone, of your explosive temperament. So what’s happening to Midoriya must be really serious, if they don’t want you to know.*

They’re not telling anyone because they don’t want to risk anyone telling me.

If they don’t want you to know, then whatever is making Midoriya bad so fast is probably serious enough for even you to want to step in.

Doubt overcame him. If All Might was willing to talk to him now, when he knew about his shitty temper, when he knew about his anger issues… Then maybe he wanted to tell Katsuki something else. Something that wouldn’t trigger his rage, something that wouldn’t force him to step in. All Might wouldn’t tell him that shitty Deku was dying when he knew damn well that Katsuki wouldn’t allow it, right?

Or…

Maybe he thought Katsuki would allow it.

Fuck.

Katsuki couldn’t quite make up his mind – should he stay and listen to what All Might had to say, when it presented a risk that he wouldn’t be able to go to Hosu without putting his career on the line, or should he leave and let that doubt gnaw at his brains?

He turned his head to look at Deku.

He looked sad, but he looked alive.

Yeah. He didn’t really have much of a choice, after all.

Katsuki didn’t want to risk letting the nerd die. If he did nothing, Deku’s demise would be in his hands. It would be his fault. And he sure as fuck didn’t need that sort of guilt on his conscience.

All Might was still staring at him, looking like he hadn’t expected such a negative response from Katsuki. Looking like he didn’t understand why Katsuki was so unwilling to hear the truth he had longed for after so long. What, had All Might really expected him to throw a fucking party and beg for information like a dog after he had spent a whole month in the dark? As fucking if. Katsuki remained silent, still glaring up at the taller man.

He would say nothing. He had made up his mind.

The look in All Might’s eyes shifted, and his face dropped in realization.

He didn’t have the highest fucking score on intelligence for nothing.

Before All Might could say anything, before he could try to shove the truth into Katsuki anyway, before he could ask about how Katsuki knew, before he could react at all, Katsuki turned on his heels and resumed his walk out of the building.

If All Might had really figured out that Katsuki already knew about the countdown, he wouldn't be able to do anything about it. He couldn't inform the other teachers or the Principal about it without simultaneously revealing that he, himself, had attempted to tell classified information to a student. On the other hand, if he *didn't* figure out, which Katsuki doubted, then…

Well. Katsuki couldn't worry about him. He had better more urgent things on his list.

When he turned his back and walked away for the last time, All Might didn't follow him or call after him again, which was the only answer he really needed.

(7) missed calls from: Deku's Mom

(3) new voicemails

From: Deku's Mom

Katsuki-kun, please call me back.

From: Deku's Mom

Katsuki-kun, I need to talk to you immediately… Please call me as soon as you can.

From: Deku's Mom

I am sorry to bother… I know you are in class... But please call me as soon as you can.

From: Deku's Mom

I left you a voicemail… Please call me back once you hear it.

From: Deku's Mom

All Might called me this morning and he told me something very disturbing. Please call me when you can…

From: Raccoon Eyes

Where u at?

From: Shitty Hair

Uhh where are you man?

From: Shitty Hair

We're having lunch at the usual place come meet us

From: Dunce Face

You're late for lunch blasty

From: Raccoon Eyes

Don't even try to pretend you're having lunch with someone else because we all know very well we're the only ones who can put up with our explodo king

From: Raccoon Eyes

(Don't get all moody you know I'm just joking)

From: Raccoon Eyes

But seriously where r u? Kiri won't shut up about you and I can't eat while he's rambling on me

From: Shitty Hair

My man……. I'm worried

From: Shitty Hair

I didn't want to say anything but you looked kind of weird this morning

From: Shitty Hair

Not Bakugou weird

From: Shitty Hair

Weird weird

From: Shitty Hair

I know how you get sometimes and it's ok if you don't wanna talk about it

From: Shitty Hair

Sorry if I overstepped with that f-word thing

From: Shitty Hair

If you need to talk, whatever this is…. You can talk to me, ok?

From: Shitty Hair

You know you can, right?

From: Shitty Hair

Even if you don't feel like talking, if you just need a hug, you can come over

From: Shitty Hair

Let me know you're ok when you can, all right man?

From: Shitty Hair

Also I still got your tie

From: Tape Guy

Mina won't leave me alone until I text you so hey man where are you we're having lunch etc

From: Tape Guy

Ok I’m just joking. But for real, where are u man?

Incoming call from: Deku’s Mom

Declined

From: Bakubro

I’m fine, stop fucking worrying

From: Shitty Hair

OH MY GOD YOU LIVE

From: Shitty Hair

Got me worried there for a sec man

From: Shitty Hair

You never skip lunch

From: Bakubro

I didn’t fkn skip lunch, I just went before you assholes did

From: Bakubro

Look Kirishima I’m busy today ok

From: Bakubro

Stop freaking out every time I disappear for two seconds

From: Bakubro

What are you a fucking puppy or smth

From: Shitty Hair

It wasn't just 2 seconds tho???

Incoming call from: Deku's Mom

Declined

From: Bakubro

Whatever. Just stop freaking out

From: Bakubro

I'm gonna turn my phone off now. I'm trusting you not to break down into a fucking sobbing fit while I'm gone

From: Bakubro

And if you show up scratching my fucking door I'm gonna blow your ass up

From: Shitty Hair

Mean :c

From: Shitty Hair

But I meant what I said earlier, ok? If you need to talk or to get a hug, just come over

From: Shitty Hair

Or talk to me

From: Shitty Hair

Ok? I'm worried

From: Bakubro

Don't fucking be. I'm fine.

From: Bakubro

Bye

Incoming call from: Deku's Mom

Declined

Power off phone?

Shutting down…

"What are you thinking about?"

"Huh?"

"You've been staring at the fucking window for thirty minutes. Even if there was a fucking All Might parade out there you wouldn't stare for so long".

Izuku turned to look at him with a blank look on his face. He seemed confused and lost.

“I don’t know. I’m just thinking”.

“Which is a fucking surprise to us all, but you still haven’t said what about”.

Izuku sighed.

“About life. About… everything”.

Katsuki stared at him.

“The day is really nice today”.

Katsuki rolled his eyes and snorted, allowing himself to drop heavily on his back against his mattress. What a bunch of sentimental bullcrap.

“*Really*?”

“I like it when it’s like this”.

“Like *what*?”

“It’s sunny, but not too hot. The breeze is cold, and there are clouds in the sky… Everything is calm and silent. All you can hear is the sound of the leaves when the wind hits them”.

Katsuki scoffed, placing both hands beneath his head in order to support it against his pillow. He closed his eyes, but his grumpy expression didn’t leave his face.

“Yeah, I could fucking use some calm and silence”.

A small chuckle.

“I agree”.

A pause.

Katsuki frowned slightly before reopening his eyes and turning on the bed in order to better scowl at Izuku.

“The fuck is that supposed to mean?”

Izuku gave him a tiny smile, which was sadder than anything else. He looked oblivious.

“Everything’s been messy for you ever since the villain attacked us”.

“Tch. Tell me the fuck about it”.

“I supposed… You’d be happy to have some peace”.

Katsuki stared at him for long moments. His gaze was scorching.

Izuku went back to staring out the window, completely unaware of the effect his words had caused on Katsuki.

He stood up from the bed.

“The fuck is wrong with you?”

Izuku looked at him again, the hint of a confused frown between his eyes.

“Huh…?”

“I asked what the fuck is wrong with you”, Katsuki repeated, taking a step closer to Izuku and glaring at him with the fury of a thousand burning suns. “Did your fucking mom drop you on your head as a baby or some shit?”

Izuku downright frowned at him.

“I… I don’t understand, Kacchan”.

Katsuki scoffed, assuming a defensive position. He had promised himself that he wouldn’t have another brawl with Deku inside his bedroom after the mess that they had caused last time, but he was ready to take the nerd down if he had to. It was like Deku was fucking begging Katsuki to punch him in the face by saying all that crap.

“You think I’m about to drag my ass over to Hosu in the middle of the damn night just because I want some fucking peace and quiet? You think *that’s* what I’ll get once you’re gone?”

Izuku stared at him in silence.

“Yeah, because I’m such a fucking *monster* that of fucking course I’ll feel happiness if you die as a result of taking a fucking blow in my place”, he scoffed again. “So tell me, did your mom drop you as a baby? Or were you born fucked up in the head? Because those are the only two explanations I have for you to look up to me like you insist you do, despite all the fucked-up shit I did to you”.

Izuku continued to stare.

“I’ve already told you several fucking times over that I was an asshole to you, that I *know* I was a fucking asshole. And guess what? I’m still an asshole, but I’m not as bad as I was before. And I find it pretty fucking offensive that I’m going through all this trouble to save you shitty life, and you still think that I’ll be fucking happy to see you gone”.

Izuku looked surprised, but Katsuki couldn’t stop now. All the pressure that was weighting down on his chest ever since the night before, all the stress and the anger and the frustration were coming out. He needed to let it all out, otherwise he would explode – literally and metaphorically.

“I don’t give a shit if you have a death wish or a god-complex. You want to die a fucking martyr? Good for you. But I won’t let you fucking use me as your damn scapegoat. I didn’t

fucking ask you to be my human fucking shield, and I won't let you die because of it. I'm gonna go after the pros, I'm gonna kick the villain's ass, and I'm gonna shove your shitty soul back into your body. If you've got a problem with that, keep it to your fucking self".

Silence.

He was panting. He was angry. There was a knot in his throat. He felt like screaming and punching a hole through Deku's face, all at the same time.

He wanted to stop time and take a break. He wanted to take a *fucking* break.

He had spent a whole fucking month doing nothing, without knowing that Deku's shitty days were counted. He had wasted time on fucking classes, on fucking trips to the mall, on fucking brawls, on fucking visits to Deku's mom, on fucking birthday parties, when in reality he should have been *doing something*. He had fucking relaxed and, what, acted like he and Deku were actually friends? Acted like being stuck with the sucker's soul was an opportunity, rather than a problem? Acted like he could actually fucking do this with Deku, as if it was normal, as if it was ok? The joke was on him. This was his mistake, not only for relaxing, but for allowing shitty nerdy Deku to give his life for him in the first place.

There was a damn person about to die because of him, and now there was little to no time to do something about it.

And he would be damned if he didn't do something about it. Worst case scenario? He failed and Deku died in four days. Best case scenario? He succeeded and he would be able to rub his victory on Deku's face for the rest of their lives.

(Not to mention his debt with Deku for all those times the nerd saved his ass would be settled and, most importantly, Deku would be alive, but those were motivations he still didn't have the nerve to admit aloud.)

Deku was still staring at him, looking at a loss for words.

"I'm going to save your dumb ass, whether you fucking want it or not", he concluded, furious at Deku, at himself, and at the world. "And *that's* the sort of fucking hero you should fucking admire".

He turned back to his bed and fell on it again, feeling like he had run a fucking marathon. He buried his eyes in the crook of his arm and decided to tune the rest of the world out.

Apparently, Deku had different plans.

"I never admired you because you were cruel".

Fucking *great*. He had almost forgotten that the nerd was a fucking master at not dropping a *fucking* subject.

"I mean… You *were* cruel. You were really cruel".

I fucking know that. You think I don't know that?

“But that was never the reason why I looked up to you. I did it because… Well”.

A pause.

“You’re amazing, Kacchan. I know I say it a lot, and I know you know it. But for a person like me to admire a person like you, it takes… *something*. You had to be really incredible for me to be able to look past all the stuff you did”.

Katsuki didn’t know how to feel about that statement.

“So yes, you beat me, and you called me names, and you put me down… You… Y-You did things that I… That I still have trouble forgetting about. Some of the stuff you said to me, they… It left a mark. I can’t overlook that. But I – I’m not a masochist. It all hurt. But it *is* like you said… There’s no use dwelling in the past”.

Hesitation.

“I already forgave you for all that. I… I need you to know that I did”.

I didn’t ask your forgiveness. I didn’t fucking ask for you goddamn fucking forgiveness, shitty Deku, stop giving it to me. I don’t need it.

I’m not even sure I fucking deserve it.

“And I admired you because of your skill. You have an amazing quirk, a powerful quirk. You had everything I wished for, but I never envied you for it… Because I – I knew t-that if anyone deserved to be grand, it was you. The way you mastered your quirk at such a young age, t-the way you trained hard and earned your place at UA… The – The way you always excelled at everything you did. The way you always worked hard to be the best, and the way you knew you earned your place… Those were the reasons why I admired you”.

Katsuki kept his eyes buried on the crook of his arm. He didn’t want to face Izuku.

“I admired you because you never gave up. You always worked hard. You always did your best. In my eyes, you are the very definition of what *Plus Ultra* means. B-But what I admired the most was t-that… It didn’t matter how hard things were. You never, ever gave up. You never *give* up, Kacchan. Whenever there is a wall in front of you, you laugh”.

Katsuki wished he could go back to the time when all he ever felt was anger – things were easier that way. He would lose control of his temper, explode, and the discomfort would disappear. Now, he didn’t know how to make what he was feeling go away. Shouting didn’t seem to help so much, apparently, and calling Deku names would only do more harm than good.

As much as he hated the very idea of it, living with Deku for almost a month and sharing his feelings with the nerd had changed him. His previous way of doing things – shouting, cursing, threatening, fighting – didn’t seem to work so well anymore.

Nothing seemed to work so well anymore.

Things were simpler when the only thing he felt for Deku was hatred.

“You are my image of victory. That’s why I know I won’t die”.

That was what finally made Katsuki uncover his eyes and turn his head to the side in order to glare at Izuku. The nerd’s face was scrunched up in an ugly grimace, as if he was about to burst into tears.

“And despite everything you did to me…”, Izuku continued. His voice was thick with emotion, but Katsuki had never seen trust so evident in a person’s eyes before – a trust which was directed at him, and him alone. “… I still love you, Kacchan. I always have”.

Katsuki stared at him.

“And I *trust* you. I *know* that we are going to find a way out of this”.

Katsuki stared at him.

Of course Deku fucking loved him. Why else would he stick around despite everything Katsuki did to him throughout their lives? Why else would he praise Katsuki, when Katsuki was horrible to him? Why else would he admire Katsuki, when all Katsuki ever did was put him down? Why else would shitty Deku stay in his life, when all Katsuki did was fucking push him away?

To think that he had spent so long taking Deku’s admiration for arrogance. To think that he used to believe Deku looked down on him, and thought himself better than him, and despised him. Now he could see – there, plain as a day, if not painfully evident in tearful green, then painfully evident in the words that had just come out through wobbly lips. He could see the admiration and the love which had always been there, from day one, and which he misread for so long. He could see how the thoughts about Deku’s arrogance and self-righteousness were only a mirror of his *own* thoughts and feelings. He could see it. He could finally see it.

He could see it, but not all of it.

And then Izuku broke down into tears, raising his hands up to his face in order to hide it away from view, his shoulders rattling with each sob that escaped his throat. For the first time ever, Katsuki didn’t feel annoyed by the sight of the boy crying.

It felt like they had finally crossed a decade-long barrier that had been standing between them; it felt like they were finally headed somewhere, along with each other, rather than away from each other.

It felt like they were finally… something. Not totally friends, no longer enemies. Not really just rivals, either.

Something more meaningful.

Years of hating Deku’s gut told Katsuki that he shouldn’t be happy that they were finally getting their shit together and getting along with each other. The nasty, petty, arrogant, and insecure part of his brain told him that he was supposed to hate Deku, and despise Deku, and

look down on Deku, no matter what. Feeling anything else – anything positive – towards the nerd was nothing but a sign of pathetic, disgusting weakness.

For the first time ever, he didn't allow himself to be taken by those petty thoughts. It didn't feel right, or fair – especially not in the situation they were in. In front of him, stood a person that was about to die because of him – *for* him, in his place. He didn't have it in himself to feel disgust or anger at Deku – and while he didn't feel gratitude, either, he did feel something else. Something yet to name, something yet to understand. Something that wasn't the rage he was used to feeling at the nerd, but something that he didn't have a name or a way of comprehending just yet.

So he stood up from the bed, walked over to Deku's sobbing form, and pulled the shaking boy into a hug that said a lot more than words ever could. It was aggressive and raw, and Deku's forehead hurt Katsuki's collarbone when it collided with it. It felt more like Katsuki was trying to squeeze Deku to death than to comfort him, but that was only because this was something Katsuki didn't know how to do. Even though he was fucking amazing at everything, he still had a long way to go before he learned how to properly comfort people.

Izuku immediately hugged him back as if he had been counting the seconds for Katsuki to hold him, still sobbing. The close contact made Katsuki uncomfortable, but not in a way that made him want to break away from the touch – in a way that made him overwhelmed. He was suddenly aware of everything – Deku's scent, the way his fingers clung and twitched on the back of his shirt, the way his shoulder rattled with each sob, the way his hair felt against his skin. It was disturbing. He wasn't used to that, not even after hugging and cuddling with the nerd.

Days of not doing so may have contributed to the uneasiness he was feeling on that moment (but that was his own fault).

He wanted to get away and to hold Deku more closely; he wanted to yell at Deku and comfort him, all at the same time. It was confusing, and awful, and an oxymoron. He hated it and longed for it at the same time. But Deku needed it. Deku needing it didn't necessarily mean Katsuki had to give it to him, but it felt wrong not to.

And yeah, of course he needed it. He was fucking *dying*.

"I'm scared, Kacchan", Izuku sobbed, clinging to Katsuki as if he was a lifeline. It was only natural – throughout all his life, Katsuki had been the only constant in Izuku's life – he was there in his homelife, as his friend, he was there in his school life, as his colleague and bully, he was there in his aspirations, as his image of victory and resistance.

It was only natural Katsuki was there at the moments of Izuku's death, just as much as he'd been there through his life.

"You'd be a damn moron if you weren't", was what Katsuki responded while he held Izuku close.

"I trust you", Izuku continued. "And I believe in you. But I'm – I'm –"

“You don’t have to explain shit”, Katsuki interrupted him, holding the boy and staring straight ahead with his usual grumpy look on his face. “I understand”.

Izuku broke away from the hug just slightly enough for him to look at Katsuki’s face.

“You do?”

Katsuki scowled at him.

“Of *course*. If I were about to kick the fucking bucket, I’d be scared, too”.

Izuku smiled, which contrasted with the tears running down his flushed cheeks.

“Really?”

“Of course I fucking would, nerd”, Katsuki rolled his eyes. “I just wouldn’t let anyone *see* it. What kind of fucking hero would I be if I shat my pants every time I was in danger?”

Izuku chuckled at this, breaking the hug but standing close to Katsuki, closer than they were used to. Izuku tried to wipe his tears away with the back of his hand, but his voice was still thick with emotion when he spoke up.

“All Might told me something similar”, he sniffed after trying to recompose himself.

“About shitting his pants?”, Katsuki deadpanned and raised an eyebrow at Izuku, who snorted a laugh through his nose.

“*No*. About not letting anyone see it when he’s scared. That’s why he always smiles”, he explained.

“Huh”, Katsuki huffed. “Who’d figure”.

He turned around in order to make his way to the bed, taking the subject for finished. Before he could take more than two steps, however, Izuku stopped him.

“Kacchan”, he called, making Katsuki look at him over his shoulder and stare at the boy.

“What?”

Izuku hesitated, biting his lower lip.

“I meant it”, he concluded after a few moments of silence. There was a serious look on his face, which was partially discredited by the tears still making his cheeks shine under the light of the sunset coming through the window. Katsuki found himself enjoying the way the red streaks of light made Izuku’s freckles stand out on his face, his green eyes and his green hair shining amongst crimson.

In color theory, green and red are complimentary colors. A juxtaposition, of sorts. A perfect opposite.

A perfect contradiction.

“Everything I said”, Izuku continued, unaware of Katsuki’s thoughts. “I meant it. If anyone can defeat this guy and save me… That’s you”.

Izuku gave him a wobbly smile. It was full of trust.

“You’re my image of a hero. Not because of your flaws, but despite them”.

Katsuki stared at him. He didn’t know how to respond.

If he was being honest, no one had ever told him something like that. One of the things he had heard the most throughout his life was that he was more like a villain than a hero, or that he was too angry to be heroic. Being kidnapped by the fucking League of Villains was just a reinforcement of something he had been dealing with ever since he was a kid. No one other than Deku had ever praised him as a proper hero, or deemed him heroic in the first place. No one had ever admired him for who he was, despite all the fucked-up stuff he may have done. They all admired him for his quirk, but not for himself.

In a way, he and Deku were like complementary colors. They were both constantly judged based on their quirks – Katsuki by his amazing one, Deku by his inexistent one. At the end of the day, no one could look past their abilities and see them for who they were.

Katsuki had spent most of his life doing that to Deku – tuning his entire existence down to a quirk. He was just too blind, too short-sighted to realize everyone else did the exact same thing to him, but for the different reasons. That was the price you paid for living in a quirk-obsessed society.

No one had ever put so much faith, so much trust in him like Deku had.

He had no idea what to do in that sort of situation, really. Every option that crossed his mind seemed too complicated, and he already had a lot to think about. A lot of broken standards, a lot of realizations.

A lot about the future.

“I’m going to take a nap”, Katsuki announced in a deadpan. He fucking hated being evasive, but what could he do? It wasn’t like he could confront Deku about what he was feeling; he didn’t even fucking know what he was feeling in the first place. “We need to be well-rested if we’re gonna do this tonight”.

Izuku nodded solemnly, as if he hadn’t expected a different response (which quite frankly pissed Katsuki off, but he couldn’t explain why), and approached Katsuki’s bed at the same time the explosive boy lay down on it. He stared at Katsuki in silence for a while with an unreadable look on his face. Katsuki stared back.

Izuku climbed into bed beside Katsuki and lied on his back.

They lied side by side, staring at the ceiling. Orange, red, and pink streaks of light colored the white surface.

“I’ll try to get some rest as well”, Izuku announced after a few moments.

Katsuki snorted.

“Doubt you’ll do it”.

“I said I’ll *try*”, Izuku smiled. Katsuki scoffed, burying his eyes between the crook of his arm again.

“Yeah, ok”.

Silence.

Spending the whole night stressing out and coming up with a failsafe took its toll on Katsuki, which meant it didn’t take him too long to begin dozing off, even with all the questions and problems dwelling at his mind. He had set his alarm – not the one in his phone, which was turned off, but the one by his nightstand – to an hour before curfew. All Might hadn’t been specific about a time, but Katsuki supposed it was only safe to assume the pros wouldn’t risk leaving school grounds while their students were still roaming around the campus. That way, they would have an hour to prepare themselves to leave and take a safe route to Hosu. Since All Might possibly knew that Katsuki was aware of Izuku’s situation, they would have to be extra careful when leaving – it wouldn’t be too crazy to expect the security on UA exits to be even more strict than usual.

He was almost being swallowed whole by the darkness of sleep when Izuku spoke up again, bringing him back to the surface.

“Hey, Kacchan?”

He sighed, annoyed.

“What?”

A pause.

“Thank you”.

He rolled his eyes, even though Izuku couldn’t see it.

“For what, nerd?”

“Going to Hosu tonight. I…”, he swallowed dry. “I know what you’re risking”.

Katsuki scoffed.

“Tch”.

“I mean it. And… Even though I know I’m not the *only* reason you’re doing this, I’m…”

A pause.

“Thank you”, Izuku settled for saying.

Katsuki stared up at his ceiling. Deku had really bought the theory that Katsuki could end up dying along with him, right? And now it was too late to tell the boy that this was *definitely* not the only reason why Katsuki was doing this.

He was doing this because it was the right thing to do. Because yes, there was a chance he could end up dying along with Deku, but he hadn’t even considered that option before Earphone Girl meddled in his business. On the other hand, having to live his life knowing Deku had died to save him – knowing that fucking Deku had thrown his life away for *him*, after everything, after their mutual promise to surpass each other – that would be… Bad. It would be fucking *bad*.

He didn’t want to owe Deku anything. He didn’t want Deku to fucking win and be the best hero. He didn’t want Deku to surpass him yet again.

But, most of all, he didn’t want Deku to die. Thinking about the reasons behind that was more troublesome than he was willing to accept, so he decided not to think about it altogether. It was less complicated like this.

He scoffed again, the familiar urge to be an asshole to Deku being hard to overcome. Old habits die hard, but he was trying to kill them faster, even if he wouldn’t admit so, not even to himself.

“You can save all the thank yous for *after* I save your shitty life”, was what he managed to say. Not as assholery as he could have been, but still pretty much assholery. “Don’t thank a man for a job that ain’t done”.

Deku chuckled, and that was all there was to it.

As Katsuki fell asleep and braced himself for what was to come, it never occurred him to tell Deku that he loved him back.

“I don’t think we can see my mom before we go?”

Katsuki stared at him for several seconds of tense silence.

“Look at my fucking face and tell me what you think is the answer to that”.

Izuku sighed, lowering his head.

“It was worth a try. And I just wanted to tell her goodbye”.

“Sure, because we have all the fucking time in the world. You wanna grab a coffee and watch a movie too while we’re at fucking Hosu? Go for a stroll in the fucking park?”

A pause, and a twitch at both their hearts. Katsuki rolled his eyes, well aware of what the nerd would say in response.

“You’re being an as–“

“I fucking *know*”.

Another pause.

“You’re stressed out”.

A scoff.

“You’re not?”

“You get even snarkier when you’re stressed out”.

“As if you know shit about me”.

“I *told* you I trust you”.

“Several fucking times over”.

“And I *am* stressed, too. I just… I wish I could see mom. One last time”.

Katsuki looked at him, studying his face for a long time.

“She knows”.

Izuku stared back at him, his big, expressive green eyes focused on Katsuki’s face with such melancholy that it would have been heartbreaking, if Katsuki was a more sensitive person.

“All Might said he would tell her, last night. ‘First thing in the morning’ or whatever. She’s been calling me like crazy ever since”.

A pregnant pause. The melancholy in Izuku’s eyes quickly shifted into indignation.

“And you didn’t *pick up*?!”

“Tch. Take a fucking guess”.

Izuku’s mouth opened and closed several times, like a fish.

“Kacchan, *what* –“

“If I picked up, she would tell me everything I already know”, he explained before Izuku could even get started. “If she or All Might fucking told me about the deadline, I wouldn’t be able to go to Hosu, because that would be directly disobeying orders. This way, it’s unofficial, and I don’t risk losing my license. It’s less risky”.

Izuku studied him. Katsuki glared at the boy.

“As much as I want to keep your ass from being dragged into the afterlife, I still don’t want to be kicked out of school”, he concluded. “So there’s that”.

Izuku bit his lower lip, staring straight ahead in deep thought. It took him a while to say anything in response and, when he did, there was a sobriety and a determination in his eyes that had been missing from his face for a while.

“I… I want you to tell her something. If things go wrong”, Izuku said, using a tone that left no space for a discussion. Katsuki’s primary urge was to respond with an angry *don’t tell me what to do, shitty nerd*, but instead, he simply continued to glare at Izuku in silence.

The boy took a deep breath, looking away for a few moments before locking eyes with Katsuki again.

“I – I want you to tell her I’m sorry. For all the pain, for everything I’ve put her through. Tell her I never meant to hurt her, and… And that she was the best mom I could have possibly asked for. T-Tell her that without her support, I would have never made it… And that none of this was her fault. All she ever did was support her son, and that is the best and only thing a parent should ever do. Tell her I’m proud of her, and I love her, and I’m –“, a shaky breath. “I’m sorry, I’m so sorry”.

Katsuki could see the tears forming in Izuku’s eyes.

“I won’t tell her shit”, he said.

Izuku frowned at him, the sudden scrunching up of his face making the tears flow freely down his cheeks. He looked a mixture of offended and betrayed. Before he could protest, Katsuki added:

“Because nothing’s going wrong. The fuck did all that trust from before go, heh?”

Izuku stared at him with a blank face for a few moments before a hint of a hesitant smile appeared at the corner of his wobbly lips.

“I’m serious, Kacchan”, he said, sniffing and running the back of his hand across his runny nose. Thought there was a smile on his face, the melancholy was still in his eyes.

“Whatever, nerd”, he scoffed, rolling his eyes. “You’re not dying, so don’t bother fucking thinking about that. You’d better save that damn energy for what we’re about to do”.

Izuku lowered his head again.

“But if it will ease your shitty heart, I’ll tell her all that bullshit”.

A soft smile appeared on Izuku's lips.

"I want to ask for something else", he added, his head bowed. Katsuki groaned and threw his head back.

"*Deku –*"

"I want to ask for something else", Izuku repeated firmly, interrupting Katsuki and lifting his chin up to stare at him.

Silence.

"If I die", Izuku swallowed dry. "Take care of my mom".

Katsuki scoffed, not knowing whether Deku was being serious.

"She will blame herself", Izuku continued. "And she doesn't know how to look after herself when she's feeling guilty. I –", he sighed, "I understand this is a lot to ask for, but… You're…", he shook his head, hesitating. "I just need to know there will be someone around to make sure she's ok. She doesn't…", he swallowed dry, sounding emotional. "She doesn't have anyone else".

Katsuki squinted his eyes at Izuku.

"Why the fuck does it have to be me? Why not All Might?"

Izuku closed his eyes softly.

"I'm fucking awesome in everything, but I *hate* comforting people or whatever it is you want me to do for your mom. You trying to humiliate me or something?"

Izuku sighed and reopened his eyes, giving Katsuki a serious look.

"I'm not trying to humiliate you, Kacchan. I can't ask All Might because I'm pretty sure he will blame himself as well", he explained, "*And* I know better than to ask *you* to look after him".

Katsuki fumed.

"You underestimating me, you damn nerd?!"

"You're the one who said you don't like this sort of thing!", Izuku protested defensively.

"Yeah, but I'm still forced to deal with a bunch of bullshit I don't like!", Katsuki yelled in response.

"Exactly, so why would I give you more of that?!", Deku retorted.

"I'd comfort the fuck out of them if your shitty ass kicked the bucket, but since that's not happening, you don't have a damn thing to worry about!"

For some deranged reason, this earned a muffled chuckle from Izuku. Kacchan really had to be competitive about everything, right?

"Fine, Kacchan", Izuku said, still smiling at Katsuki's rage-distorted face. Katsuki gave him a victorious smirk in response, just before Izuku added: "And just so you know, I *know* you like my mom. That's why I asked you".

The smile on Katsuki's lips turned immediately into a scowl.

"The fuck does that mean?"

"We share feelings, Kacchan. I know you like it when she hugs you".

"Shut the *fuck* up".

"I can't blame you. She gives the best hugs".

"If you don't stop with that creepy talk, I'm kicking your teeth in".

"I wish I could hug her one last time".

Katsuki's scowl grew more intense.

"God, you're such a dramatic piece of fuck. You're worse than that French Belt Guy".

A chuckle.

"You mean Aoyama?"

"Whatever that fuckface's name is".

The smile died from Izuku's lips and he was silent for a while. When he spoke up again, the melancholy in his eyes had increased by a tenfold.

"I… I would actually like to leave a message for everyone".

"I already told you we don't have the fucking time for that".

Izuku stared at him with a serious face.

"Kacchan".

"*What*?"

"I could die".

"Yeah, in *four fucking days*. It's not like it's all fucking over for you if things go wrong today. If the mission blows to hell and we don't capture this asshole, I'll write your shitty testament for you tomorrow. Don't worry, I'll make sure to evenly split all your All Might underwear between Round Face and Icy Hot", he smirked evilly, and rejoiced on the way Izuku immediately blushed. *That* would shut the fucking nerd up.

“T-That’s…! That’s n-not – I don’t – I don’t e-even know w-what – I mean – I, I…”

“Oh, shut the fuck up”, he rolled his eyes and turned his back on the blushing nerd.

Izuku took a few moments to recompose himself before chasing after Katsuki.

“I – I don’t know w-what y-you meant by that, b-but I was serious, Kacchan, I really –“

“Yeah, I know you were fucking serious”, Katsuki interrupted unceremoniously. “And I already told you that, if things go wrong, which isn’t *fucking happening*, I’ll deliver your shitty messages around”.

Izuku stared at him.

“*What*?”

“It’s just…”

“Just *spit* it, Deku. We’ve talked about the fucking stuttering”.

Izuku bit his lower lip and bowed his head.

“It’s nothing. You’re right. Even if things don’t work tonight, we’ll still… *I’ll* still have four days”.

“Yeah”.

“Yeah, ok”.

“Good. Can we fucking go, now?”

Hesitation.

“Is it time already?”

“What sort of fucking question is that? You think we can magically get to fucking Hosu in five minutes?”

A sigh.

“You really can’t help yourself, can you, Kacchan?”

“I sure as hell try, but you don’t make it fucking easy”.

“You’re the one who said you don’t like it easy”.

“Shut *up*, shitty Deku”.

“Typical”.

“Fuck off”.

A pause, and a sad smile.

“I think I’ll miss this”.

Katsuki scoffed.

“What? Being a fucking ghost?”

“No. Being around you”.

Katsuki stared at him with a frown. He didn’t know why, but those words had made him feel something weird. Something off. Something new.

Izuku didn’t meet his eyes.

“The fuck?”

A hesitant shrug.

“I don’t know. We’ve hung out more in this past month than we did in eleven years”.

Katsuki scoffed.

“Yeah, because your soul is fucking glued to mine”.

Izuku gave him a half-hurt, half-impatient look. Katsuki rolled his eyes in response.

“I just… Despite everything, I kind of liked it”.

Katsuki scowled.

“You’re a fucking weirdo, Deku”.

“Stop saying that”.

“I’ll stop when you stop being such a fucking weirdo”.

It was Izuku’s time to eyeroll.

“All I’m saying is that…”, he trailed off, sighing. Katsuki stared at him, waiting for some sort of conclusion. “Well. I hope we don’t go back to…”, he trailed off again.

“To what?”

Izuku looked at him.

“You know. What we had before”.

“So fucking *nothing*?”

Izuku chuckled humorlessly.

“What we had was worse than nothing. It was…”

Katsuki kept staring at him. Izuku looked away.

“It wasn’t nice. I mean, it was slowly getting better, but it wasn’t… *nice*”.

Katsuki snorted.

“And what we have now, well…”, Izuku shrugged. “I like it better”.

He looked at Katsuki again, waiting for a response. Katsuki stared back, not knowing what to say.

His relationship with Deku hit the point of no return in the moment they hugged each other voluntarily. The moment when they cuddled – the moment when Katsuki finally admitted to himself that maybe sharing physical touch with Deku wasn’t all that bad; maybe being close to Deku wasn’t that gruesome; maybe seeing Deku as something different from the pretentious bastard he always thought him to be wasn’t all that ridiculous – those were the event horizon of their relationship. It didn’t feel right to go back to what they used to have just because Deku would be back inside his body. It didn’t feel right to go back to hating Deku.

Much to his surprise, Katsuki realized he couldn’t quite bring himself to go back to hating Deku.

Well, *fuck*.

He didn’t know what he felt for Deku, though. It wasn’t hate anymore – but something as intense. It felt like a messed-up mixture of repulse, second-hand embarrassment, admiration, fondness, and… something scorching. Something that burned deeply in his chest and that sent fire to his eyes whenever he thought about the nerd. It wasn’t rage, anymore – but rather a direct opposite, some sort of juxtaposed feeling that was just intense as rage without quite being it.

“I know you like it better, too. Even if you don’t admit it”, Izuku broke him away from his thoughts. Katsuki glared at him, defensive.

“You don’t know shit about me”.

Izuku smiled.

“Actually, I think I’m finally starting to get you”.

“You took your fucking time”.

“Well, you don’t exactly *make it easy*, Kacchan”, Izuku said jokingly, paraphrasing Katsuki’s words from before.

“Why the fuck would I make things easy for you?”

Izuku smiled fondly.

“You’re right. But it was worth it, you know”.

“What?”

Izuku stared at him.

“Getting to know you. Even if it had to be like this”.

Katsuki’s chest felt warm. He didn’t know how to react, which, as usual, put him on defensive mode.

“You’re fucked up, Deku”.

All Izuku offered him as a response was a small smile.

His trust in Kacchan left no space for fear in his heart.

One pair of footsteps was echoing soundly on the wet floor.

He knew it, he just *knew it*, that Deku couldn’t fucking wait to run his mouth and start asking a billion questions about what they were doing, but thankfully the nerd knew better than to do that. Even if he was a dumb bastard, Deku must have figured out what Katsuki’s plan was as soon as they stepped into the sewers.

Still, the nerd was fidgety and tense as they walked alongside each other, only Katsuki’s steps resulting on any sound. He assumed Deku must have been nervous about the fact that he was quite literally dying. Even if they both knew he would triumph, there was a lot more at stake than just Deku’s life.

(Even though that was the most important part. For both of them).

Despite what no one thought *ever*, Katsuki wasn't stupid. He knew All Might was onto him – the fact that he hadn't insisted on talking to him earlier, the fact that he had just let Katsuki *walk away* – was evidence enough that the man was suspicious. Suspicion often led to surveillance – so Katsuki had no doubt that, being as smart as All Might was, he would make sure to secure all possible exits of UA to prevent anyone (but most importantly, Katsuki) from sneaking out.

Which was why he had to make a slight shift in his careful plans and opt for a route out that was more discreet. And, unfortunately, more unsanitary, too.

Deku opened and closed his mouth like a fish, looking like he was desperate to just *say* something, but upon a simple silent glare from Katsuki, he closed his lips and nodded briefly, indicating his compliance. While they climbed down the stairs to the sewer system, Katsuki's final warning to Izuku was that, even though they would be safer traveling down there, they should still be quiet in order not to draw unnecessary attention.

So they kept on walking, side by side, the silence between them growing tenser by the second.

Katsuki had an angry scowl on his face, his hands tightened into fists. Even though he was completely sure of his own ability to take down the villain who had attacked them on that alley a million years ago, he couldn't help but to feel, buried deep down at the back of his brain, the anticipated anxiety that always appeared inside him whenever he was about to engage in something dangerous. Because this wasn't just his life and his career at stake, here. It was someone else's.

It was Deku's.

Was that how heroes felt all the time?

It sort of angered Katsuki that he had somehow ended up falling so low as to putting Deku's priorities in front of his. It felt as if his brain had some sort of monthly backup system – so the backup from the previous month, from when he still hated and despised the stupid, useless Deku, was trying its hardest to overrule him and make him hate Deku again. Because he had spent his entire life hating Deku, hadn't he? The unnatural thing was *not* hating him. Liking Deku, caring for him, cuddling with him, risking his damn career – which was the only thing that he ever cared about in his damn life – over Deku… It was all alien. It was all wrong. And Katsuki didn't like it.

But he couldn't help feeling it.

He knew that he would never be able to just turn on his heels and walk away. He wouldn't be able to return to his bedroom at UA and go to sleep without doing anything, knowing that there was a fight happening over Deku's life while he lay in bed uselessly. He wouldn't be able to just sit there and not be a part of the action.

Negligence wasn't in his nature. More than that – neglecting glory wasn't in his nature. Because that was what he would get if he managed to save shitty Deku when UA's pro heroes failed to do so several times over, right? *Glory*.

And he knew he should feel like a prick for feeling that way, but he couldn't help himself. Years of being told that he was amazing, incredible, the best of the best, had taken their toll on Katsuki's ego. And surely, once his parents realized he was getting way too cocky, they tried to tone it down (even though his mom's methods of putting him down at every opportunity were questionable at best), but it was already too late. For Katsuki, all that had ever mattered was being the indisputable number one.

Which was why he was feeling fucking conflicted, as his and Deku's footsteps echoed across the sewers. Because in one hand, he really didn't want Deku to die. His past self would hate him for that, but it was the truth. If he had the means to save shitty Deku from kicking the bucket, he would do it. And he *had* the means to.

On the other hand, the cocky, arrogant part of himself that he didn't seem to be able to tone down wanted him to save Deku because that would mean he was better than the pros. And it was really useful to have that sort of recognition.

It was a mixture of both feelings – wanting to keep Deku from dying and wanting to prove he was UA's top-notch – that convinced him it was worth to risk his future license and career over… this.

It was also what convinced him that going through the sewers, as disgusting as that fucking was, was a good plan.

Their sewer system was actually pretty neat when compared to other parts of the world. If Katsuki had more time, or more sensibility, he would have taken the chance to admire the tall columns that went all the way up to the dark, black ceiling, or the overall architecture of the gallery that seemed to have been so well thought of. If it wasn't for the smell, Katsuki wouldn't have guessed this was a place through where people's wastes passed through.

Everything had changed in the world after the first person with a quirk was born. They evolved a lot as a species, but they also didn't – most of the technological advance the human race achieved after quirks was aimed to quirk control itself, and not other aspects that had been skyrocketing previously. That was why they had never been, as a species, to another planet, but they had managed to build hazardous quirk-containing chambers with the same material from spaceships.

In a way, quirks had become everything in their society. The technological development revolved around it, the career-choosing revolved on it, their whole damn lives revolved on it. That was why not having a quirk meant you were nothing – or better, worse than nothing. Being quirkless was equivalent to being a beetle stuck on its back – it was pathetic, a little sad, and absolutely helpless. Some people took pity on the beetle, and helped it, because it would always need another person's help. Other people thought the beetle's weakness was disgusting, and did nothing for them. Other people stomped on them, just because they had the power to do so, just because they were stronger than the beetle. Cruel kids liked to do that.

Katsuki had been a cruel kid.

He had been a fucking cruel kid, and even though he knew part of that was due to his whole damn socialization process, which was flooded with quirk glorification, he also knew part of that had to do with himself, and himself alone. Because him mistreating Deku, and bullying him, and putting him down was no one's fault other than his. Because he didn't have to go that far. Most kids in their school just ignored Deku, just put up with his weak, annoying, helpless presence. But not Katsuki.

Katsuki went out of his way to make Deku feel bad about himself, to make Deku hate himself for not having the luck of being born with something that Katsuki was lucky enough to have been gifted with.

Yeah, he had been a fucking asshole. He could see that now. Surely, it took fucking Deku screaming that very phrase at his face several times for him to see it, but he could *see* that now.

And part of him wanted to argue that this was just his nature. He acted like around everyone, so Deku wasn't a case apart, right? He shouldn't be so fucking upset by it. Katsuki called his friends names all the time – Kirishima was his goddamn best friend and he still called him "Shitty Hair" –, but deep down, he knew things with Deku were different.

Because everyone Katsuki knew had a quirk from early childhood, and Deku had only recently obtained one. Whatever comment Katsuki launched at Deku was made ten times worse by this fact alone.

So yeah. His asshole-ish behavior that all his other friends seemed to endure didn't have the same effect on Deku. Of course it fucking didn't. Not only because the nerd was sensitive as fuck, but also because – well.

Because Deku was different.

He had always been different. And Katsuki had spent most of those 11 years where they grew up together thinking that difference was a bad thing, or thinking that it made Deku inferior to him, but he could see the truth now.

Deku had always been a fucking hero, with or without a quirk. And that still drove Katsuki up the wall.

"Kacchan?"

He gritted his teeth and said nothing.

"Uh… Are you ok?"

Katsuki snapped his head to the side to glare at Izuku, still silent.

"It's just you're clenching your fists –"

"What did I say about keeping fucking *quiet*?"

Izuku stared at him.

“I know, but you look like your hands are about to start popping”.

A throbbing vein appeared at Katsuki’s temple. Shitty Deku had to be clever about everything right? Like fucking always. That was one of the main reasons why Katsuki had always hated his guts. The guy was fucking quirkless, he couldn’t even look after his damn self, and he still thought himself superior enough to look after *other* people. People who were stronger and better than him. He loved to put up that fucking ‘I-can’t-help-but-being-heroic’ act, and that was what pissed Katsuki off the most.

You still have a long path to go, Young Bakugou, if you really think Young Midoriya’s altruism is an act. You, of all people, should know from first-hand experience that being selfless is something that he cannot help but doing.

Ah, fuck that. *Fuck* that. He fucking hated this shit.

He fucking hated it that he now knew All Might was right.

And he fucking hated that he had already gone through all the possible stages of hating Izuku, and trying to comprehend Izuku. He had already come to terms with the nerd, right? He had already acknowledged that the nerd admired him, rather than look down on him; he had already understood that the nerd respected him, rather than despise him. Why was he still trying to convince himself that he should hate Deku? Why couldn’t he just move the fuck on from that?

He probably owed Izuku an apology. For everything. He *knew* he did. And still…

He was too proud to say it. The last thing he wanted was to fuel the nerd’s sense of self-righteousness, even if he now knew that was non-existent.

“Just shut your damn mouth”, was what he ended up saying instead. Defensive as always.

And then they went back to being silent. Nothing other than the echoes of both their footsteps were echoing across the large, tall chambers of the sewer system.

Wait a fucking second.

Deku’s footsteps had been echoing alongside Katsuki’s for a while now, he thought. Which wasn’t fucking right, since the asshole was a ghost.

Which could only mean two things.

Either Deku was turning corporeal, which was fucking unlikely, or…

Katsuki tilted his head to the side in order to check Deku out. Deku stared back at him with a puzzled look. Katsuki nodded at Deku’s feet, and then back at Deku. Katsuki tapped his own ear.

Deku frowned at him for a split second before his eyes widened in realization. He had understood Katsuki's message.

Someone was following them.

Katsuki had a really good suspicion of who it was, but he didn't want to risk jumping to conclusions. It could be a fucking villain. It could be the damn villain who had kicked their asses and shoved them into this whole mess in the first place. Katsuki's instinct was yelling at him to just jump into action and attack, but his strategical brain knew better than to risk something impulsive like that.

If this was who Katsuki thought it was, he couldn't communicate with Deku out loud without risking being overheard. Which meant he couldn't tell Deku about his fucking plan. Which meant he would have to trust Deku's slow brain to catch up with his intentions.

Katsuki held up a hand at Deku, indicating he should stop walking. He, himself, continued walking in his regular pace, but Deku took the hint and came to a stop.

The second pair of footsteps continued.

They weren't Deku's.

Katsuki indicated for Deku to go back to walking, and waited until the boy had caught up with him in order to whisper, as low as possible, in the boy's ear:

"Deku, I think we're being followed. Stop walking".

Izuku frowned in confusion, but did as Katsuki said. Katsuki continued walking.

The second pair of footsteps stopped.

Katsuki smirked, pleased with himself. He came to a stop as well, turning on his heels in order to look at the darkness behind himself and Deku, who was just a few feet behind Katsuki.

There was only one person who would be able to listen to his voice in such a low tone.

"Turn around and go the fuck back, Earphone Girl", Katsuki said in his regular tone. "I told you I was doing this alone".

The footsteps restarted, and in less than a minute, Jirou emerged from the darkness behind them. She had a determined look on her face.

"You can't stop me from coming with you", she said simply, defiantly. Katsuki scowled.

"*Eh*?"

"I'm serious. You just can't stop me. What are you going to do, Bakugou, blow me up back into UA?", she tilted her chin up slightly. Katsuki scoffed.

“You fucking *bet*”, he clenched his hands into fists.

“You do that and I’ll go to Principal Nezu”, she threatened. “I’ll tell All Might and Aizawa sensei and everyone who’s willing to listen that you sneaked out of school after curfew and engaged in an important mission without clearance from the pros”.

Katsuki could feel the heat of his rage blossoming inside of him.

“You fucking *threatening* me?”, he growled through gritted teeth, taking a few menacing steps closer to her. This girl had some fucking nerve.

“Yes, I am”, she said, unfaltering, standing her ground. “Just as much as you, I’m training to be a hero. And I won’t step aside and do nothing just because you’re under the impression you can boss me around”.

Katsuki fumed, hands threatening to start popping loudly. Izuku tried to hold him back by holding a hand to his chest, but Katsuki simply shoved the hand away with violence.

“Are you fucking *dumb*? I’m trying to save your ass, too”, Katsuki spat at her, furious. Jirou continued to stare up at him with anger and defiance.

“Thanks, but I don’t need you to save me”, she retorted. “*You’re* the one who’ll be in trouble if you go alone”.

“You underestimating me, scum?”, Katsuki growled, taking another step closer to her.

“No. I’m stating facts. You’re going on an important mission and you’re outnumbered. Even if you *are* good, you’re not a pro yet. You can’t take down a mob of villains –“

“Just fucking *watch me* –“

“And I’m not risking Midoriya’s life just because you’re *stubborn*!”, she ended up raising her voice over Katsuki’s angry, guttural one.

He stared at her.

“You don’t have a choice in this. I’m going with you, and that’s final. It’s not like you can stop me, anyway”, she concluded, walking past him. Before she could go far, Katsuki grabbed the girl’s wrist, forcing her to halt. Jirou tried to release herself from Katsuki’s grasp, but failed, staring at him with annoyance instead.

“You don’t think I can fucking stop you?”, he growled, furious. “You think you’re fucking better than me?”

“Kacchan, I think you should –“

“I think you’re not going to want to waste time *arguing* with me in the middle of the sewer system and end up missing the battle at Hosu”, Jirou told him with stern eyes, standing her ground even though Katsuki had his hand firm around her wrist. “Every second you spend trying to fight me on this is one second less you have to get there”.

Katsuki glared down at her with such intensity that, if looks could kill, Jirou would have been obliterated on the spot. Jirou stared up at him with cold, stern eyes. Izuku's gaze shifted between the two of them, as he clearly didn't know what to do.

"K-Kyouka-chan is right. Let go of her".

All heads in the precinct turned to look at the source of the voice.

Uraraka emerged from the darkness of the sewer tunnel, followed closely by Iida and…

The fucking *Icy Hot*.

Katsuki would fucking kill Earphone Girl. He would *kill* her.

"G-Guys…? What are you doing here?", Jirou asked, confusion evident in her face, at the same time Deku whispered: "Kacchan, this isn't good".

Todoroki stepped forwards in front of his pair of friends. He was wearing his usual stoic expression on his face as he looked at Katsuki, who, in response, let go of Jirou and turned to face the boy directly, making sure to wear his anger evidently on his face.

"When I saw Bakugou drag you out of the party, I knew he was up to something", Todoroki explained, the fucking *audacity*. "I also knew that, if he had found something out, he wouldn't tell me".

"I saw Kyouka-chan sneaking out of the dorm", Uraraka stepped, looking worried and determined. "After Todoroki-kun told us about what happened at the party, I saw it fit to tell him what I had seen. I – I figured it had something to do with Deku-kun".

Katsuki growled at the trio, so angry he was almost feral. This wasn't fucking according to his plans. In fact, this could fucking ruin everything. The more people he took with him, the higher the chances he would get fucking caught. He didn't need their help, and he certainly didn't need them as a liability.

He found Iida standing behind Icy Hot and Round Cheeks, looking as solemn as always.

"What about you, Four Eyes?", Katsuki growled. "The fuck are you doing here with this bunch of clowns?"

"Hey –!"

"It does not please me to break the rules like this", Iida explained, gesticulating and sounding as fucking robotic as ever. "I believe it would be best to trust our teachers and the authorities of UA! However…", he looked around at the face of his friends in the darkness, a sense of self-righteousness etched into his sharp features. He looked back at Katsuki. "Midoriya-kun is a valued friend. He put himself at risk for me back at Hosu. It is only right I repay the favor and do the same for him".

"Iida-kun…", Izuku shook his head, taking a step closer to his friend and wearing disapproval and worry in his face. His plea fell into deaf ears. "Don't do this. It's too

dangerous. And you don't owe me anything. You should go back with Uraraka-san and Todoroki-kun. It's bad enough Jirou-kun came along –"

"I'm not saying any of that shit", Katsuki interrupted with annoyance, at the same time Jirou said:

"How do you know we're going to Hosu?"

Iida frowned at Katsuki, then at her.

"I do not", he offered, confused.

"We are going to Hosu?", Uraraka asked, equally taken aback.

"I think it's time you tell us what's really going on, Bakugou", Todoroki dared not only to address him directly, but also to *demand* things from him. Katsuki scowled at him, approaching the half-and-half bastard. He was so focused on Todoroki and his burning rage for the guy that he didn't notice the way Deku was staring off at the distance with a puzzled look on his face, as if he had just heard something.

"Uh, Kacchan –"

"And I think it's time you shut the fuck up and mind your *own fucking business*!", Katsuki all but shouted at the boy, who remained impassive. Izuku gave the angry Katsuki one final look before he walked further into the tunnel, in the direction he and Katsuki had originally been heading for. No one noticed.

"This is Midoriya's safety we are talking about, so it *is* my business", Todoroki replied coldly.

"Why the fuck you even care so much about the nerd, huh? You're his fucking boyfriend or something?"

"*Eeh*?!?!"

"Oh my god…"

"Bakugou-kun! This is not appropriate –"

"No", Todoroki responded simply, completely unaffected by Katsuki's words. There was something in his heterochromatic eyes, though. Something that looked almost like anger – except, unlike Katsuki's, Todoroki's anger was *cold*. "But unlike you, I am his *friend*. And I think it's safe to say that every single person in this room cares more about Midoriya than you ever have throughout your life, even though you've known him for over a decade and we've known him for barely a school year".

Yeah, that was it.

Katsuki charged at Todoroki, vicious explosions popping in his hands.

“Bakugou, no!”

“So much for not drawing attention, huh!”

“Bakugou-kun, stop immediately!”

“You better bring all you’ve got into this, Icy Hot!”, he screamed as Todoroki gracefully dodged his attack.

He managed to use his right and freeze Katsuki’s legs all the way up to his waist, but before he could get any further, Katsuki skillfully blew the ice up and charged again. Uraraka and Jirou jumped at the explosive boy and held him back, whereas Iida placed himself in front of Todoroki to prevent him from attacking.

“Kacchan!”

“What excuse are you gonna use now, huh?”, Katsuki shouted, trying to yank himself away from both girls’ grasps. “You gonna let that four-eyed bastard hold you back? Fucking *come at me*, you piece of shit! I’ll kill you!”

“Bakugou, stop!”

“Kacchan!”

“I’m just trying to help Midoriya, which is something *you* don’t seem to be so interested in doing, since you’d rather waste your time fighting me than to just go on your way”, Todoroki retorted, barely raising his voice as he shoved Iida away.

“I can kick your ass *and* save Deku’s at the same time”, Katsuki growled as Uraraka and Jirou continued to hold him back. “And I sure as fuck don’t need your fucking help to do that”.

“Then let’s go”, Todoroki told him coldly. “I’m not interested in fighting you”.

“Kacchan! Listen to me! There are –”

“Why, because you know you’ll fucking *lose*?”, he growled, managing to shove Jirou away. Uraraka remained strong, clinging to Katsuki’s arm as if it was a lifeline and being the only thing keeping Katsuki from jumping at Todoroki’s neck.

“Because I have better things to do with my time”, Todoroki responded simply.

Katsuki shoved Uraraka away, making the girl drop on her side, and all but launched himself at Todoroki again.

“Kacchan, we’ve got incoming –!“

A loud explosion broke all the students away from whatever fight could be starting on that moment. The loud noise echoed and reverbed throughout the entire tunnel, going across it and all the way up to the shadowed ceiling. Tiny pieces of debris fell from the top, hitting the

floor around them and filling the moist air with dust. Whoever had been standing prior to the explosion fell to the floor, including Katsuki, who fell right on the top of Todoroki, and before anyone knew better, they were all staring at Katsuki with disapproval on their faces.

“Kacchan! There are villains on the sewer!”, Izuku finally found his way to Katsuki and grabbed him by the arm, meaning to call his attention and help him to his feet. Katsuki shoved Deku’s hand away and stood up on his own, coughing a bit from the dust and trying to make sense of what was happening.

“Are you kidding me, Bakugou? What the hell is *wrong* with you?”, Jirou was shouting, clutching her ears and stumbling her way to her feet with Uraraka’s help. “If they hadn’t noticed our absence from the school by now, they sure as hell will now!”

“I didn’t do this”, Katsuki said past his coughs.

“Bakugou-kun! This is unacceptable behavior from an UA student! You should know better than to lose control of your quirk –“

“You probably woke up the whole damn dorm –“

“I’m telling you I didn’t fucking *do* this, Ears!”, he screamed at the top of his lungs, only to go back to coughing immediately. Everyone stared at him, but Izuku was the only one with concern in his eyes. He placed a comforting hand on Katsuki’s shoulder.

“He’s right, kids”, a foreign voice came from the darkness behind them before Izuku could say anything. “He didn’t do this”.

All heads turned at the direction of the voice. A woman with short purple hair and menacing eyes was staring down at them, a vicious smirk on her face.

“I did”, she smiled.

And then she aimed another blast in the direction of Uraraka and Jirou.

Todoroki stepped down his foot and raised up a huge wall of ice at the same time Katsuki jumped at the two girls in order to shove them out of the way. The energy beam hit the ice and made it explode in a thousand little pieces which would have harmed Katsuki, had he not produced two large explosions to melt them.

Before the smoke could settle down or any of them could say anything, Katsuki was already charging at the woman at full speed, using the explosions he was emitting from his hands as a way to propel himself across thin air. Once his furious form was launched off the curtain of smoke, the woman charged at him again.

“Kacchan!”, Izuku yelled desperately at the same time Katsuki used a well-timed explosion to throw himself away from the woman’s aim, making her energy beam hit the wall directly behind him.

“One of you assholes find a way to tell All Might that Hosu is a fucking hoax”, Katsuki shouted over the sound of his explosions and the villain’s beams of energy hitting the walls,

because that was the immediate conclusion his brain reached. If there were villains in the fucking sewers headed to UA, then the whole Hosu shit had to be a distraction.

He was being very mindful not to place himself in front of or near any of the sewer's columns – the last thing he needed was to mess up with the structure of the place and have the ceiling collapse on them in case an explosion destroyed one of the pillars.

"There's no signal here!", Uraraka shouted, her phone in her hands.

"Then go the fuck back up and do it, Round Face!", Katsuki shouted. Behind him, Todoroki charged at the villain, too, missing her by millimeters.

"It's not really clever to yell your plan at your enemy, kid!", the villain smirked, aiming a blast at Uraraka.

Todoroki managed to raise another wall of ice in front of the girl to protect her, but trying to fight the villain and protect his friends at the same time was a bit too much. If Uraraka hadn't instinctively dodged out of the way, she would have been painfully caught by half of the blow, which was all Todoroki managed to stop with his quirk. Her cheap phone fell to the floor and cracked, instantly broken beyond repair.

"No!", Uraraka yelled, holding one of her arms close to herself. She probably hurt it when she fell full-weight on it.

"On it!", Jirou announced, getting up from where she had been shielding herself behind the remain of one of Todoroki's ice walls and running back the way they had come from. "Iida, boost me up! We need to tell All Might that Hosu is a distraction!"

"*Hai*!", Iida nodded, picking Jirou up and running back into the tunnel towards UA as fast as his quirk allowed him. He would rather stay and help his friends fight this villain, but they didn't have time for hesitation. Warning All Might and the pros was the current priority. The villain tried to stop him with another energy beam, but Todoroki successfully blocked it with his ice this time.

The failed attack against Iida gave Katsuki an opening to finally reach the woman and knock her down to the floor with a well-aimed explosion to her chest, which sent her flying back and colliding with a wall. Launching his way to her fallen form and planting himself on the top of her before she could try and get up, Katsuki placed his hand against her face and pinned her head down on the floor. She raised her arms up, quite possibly attempting to charge her quirk, which seemed to come from her hands, just like Katsuki's. Before she could do anything, however, Katsuki allowed the hand holding her face down to heat up as a warning.

"You try anything funny, I'll blow your fucking brains out", he said with a vicious smirk. Todoroki, Uraraka and Deku approached the scene, panting and looking worried. The woman set her hands down, compliant, but she smiled at Katsuki.

"They really were right when they said we shouldn't come through the sewers", she said, even though the words came out muffled by Katsuki's hand pressing down on her cheek.

“They should have fucking told you not to come *at all*”, was Katsuki’s retort, at the same time Todoroki asked: “Who’s ‘we’?”

“When they told me UA was training a boy that behaved like a villain, I didn’t buy it”, the woman continued, ignoring Todoroki’s question just as much as Katsuki did. “I’m not one to watch the news or believe in gossip. But now, looking at you…”, Katsuki could feel her facial muscles stretch beneath his palm as her smile grew wider. “I can see why they thought that”.

Ok. Low blow, but nothing he wasn’t used to. He increased the heat on his hand and leaned in closer to her.

“I’d shut my damn mouth if I were you”, he threatened through a hiss.

“How else would you come up with the *exact same plan* as the villains, kid?”, the woman raised a scornful eyebrow at him. “Using the *sewers*? That’s not heroic. Face it, you’d be better off –”, she scoffed in disdain, but before she could continue, Katsuki shoved her face down harder against the dirty concrete. She groaned in discomfort.

“Kacchan”, Izuku said from behind him, his voice urgent. “I think there’s more villains with her. I couldn’t see them, but I heard her talking to someone. We should – We should check to make sure –“

“Round Face. Icy Hot”, Katsuki interrupted him, never taking his eyes off the villain beneath him. “Go further into the tunnel. Check if she’s got company”.

“But my phone is broken and there’s no light”, Uraraka responded on impulse.

“The fuck does Icy Hot have a left side for?”, Katsuki turned to glare at Todoroki. “You fucking love Deku so much? *Use it*”.

Todoroki stared at Katsuki for a long time.

And then he nodded.

He and Uraraka walked past Katsuki and into the sewers, whereas Katsuki stayed back, still pinning the villain down on the floor.

“Spit it”, he instructed simply once the pair was gone. Deku approached him and crouched down beside the woman, studying her face.

“As I was saying, I think your talents are being wasted in this hero business when you could –“

“I don’t give a single shit what you think”, Katsuki pressed down against her face. “Unless you wanna have my fucking handprint on your face for the rest of your damn life, you’re gonna tell me what’s the fucking plan here. Where’s the soul-splitting asshole?”

The villain couldn’t turn her head, so she looked at Katsuki through the corner of her eyes, that disgusting smile still etched on her lips. Katsuki wanted to wipe that off so fucking

badly.

“Why would I tell you any of that?”

“Because I’m pretty sure you wanna fucking live to see another day”.

“Is that what you’re going to do, *hero*?”, the word was filled with scorn. “You’re going to kill me?”

Katsuki gritted his teeth, the heat of the palm pressing down on the woman’s face increasing by a tenfold. Izuku placed a hand on his shoulder, but Katsuki didn’t look at him, or acknowledge his presence at all.

Ever since this woman appeared, Katsuki had been completely ignoring Deku’s presence. He couldn’t care less if the asshole’s touchy feelings would be hurt by that – there was a lot more at stake here.

Because Katsuki *knew* the villains knew Deku’s soul hadn’t ended up with the man who detached it from the body, but they didn’t know that it was stuck to Katsuki. For all they knew, Deku’s soul was still around its shitty body, and Katsuki wasn’t about to break the news for them. Not when it could backfire.

“Kacchan. She’s stalling for time. We should restrain her and go after Todoroki-kun and Uraraka-san. There are probably more villains, and they’re going to need backup”.

Katsuki didn’t look at him, didn’t nod, or didn’t do anything that could indicate there was someone talking to him. Instead, he continued to glare down at the woman.

“You look kind of cute, you know. Concentrated like that. You’d have to lose that face in order to become a villain”, she added after a few moments of silence.

“Tch”, was Katsuki’s response.

“But, you know, even though you’re smart and all that”, she shrugged, despite the difficulty that movement demanded, since there was the whole weight of another person atop of her. “You’re still a schoolboy. Which means there’s a lot you still have to learn”, she raised one of her fists, opening it in order to show Katsuki what was inside. It looked like some sort of electronical beacon. “Like how you should always watch the hands, for example”.

Katsuki immediately blew the thing off her hand on instinct with his free own before she could do anything with it, earning a pained hiss from the woman. The burnt device fell to the floor with a dry clacking sound, broken beyond repair, and the woman snarled up at Katsuki rather than smiling at him, like she had been doing so far.

“You fucking *idiot*”, she growled painfully. “You think I hadn’t pressed the button already? The Soulmonger will show up any minute now, and then he’ll show you where you can shove those explosive hands of yours –“

“Shut the fuck up”, Katsuki said. He removed his hand from the woman’s face, only to place it on the floor directly beside his head.

Then he set off an explosion.

It wasn't strong enough to kill her – despite what everyone seemed to fucking think, he wasn't a damn villain –, but enough to give her a concussion that would leave her out cold for a while. Deku had been right – it was unlikely she had come alone to the sewers, and the pair of idiots that were Deku's friends wouldn't be able to deal with a hoard of villains on their own. They would need Katsuki.

Plus, if she had really activated that thing, whatever it was, it meant that they would have company soon, in the case they didn't have already.

He needed to work fast.

Katsuki got off the unconscious woman and left her where she was, aware that his own blast had been more than enough to guarantee at least a few hours of unconsciousness. Then he got up to his feet, tapped the dust off his clothes and started walking in the same direction as Icy Hot and Round Face.

"Kacchan", Izuku called after him, struggling to catch up with him. He didn't stop.

He didn't have time to stop.

"Kacchan, wait!"

Everything was going wrong, and he had to fix it, *fast*.

"Kacchan!"

Matte yo, Kacchan!

"*What*?", Katsuki asked through gritted teeth, more aggressively than he had meant to. Izuku stared at him with wide eyes, looking at a loss for words – as if he hadn't expected that sort of response.

"Was – Was this part of your plan?", Izuku asked, sounding like he sincerely didn't know how wrong those words would sound to Katsuki.

"Does it fucking *look* like it was part of my plan?"

Izuku swallowed dry with a determined look on his face.

"So what is the plan now?"

"Shut up, go after that pair of idiots, find the villains and fight them off".

"Okay", Izuku nodded patiently. "But that's even riskier than the previous plan. Right? Before, we would only fight the Soulmonger –"

"Don't fucking call him that. It's ridiculous".

“Fine, whatever, we would just fight… *him*. And then flee. Without getting seen. Without being caught”.

“So?”

“So now you’re planning on going after several possible villains to fight them off! And you sent Jirou-san and Iida-kun after the pro heroes! Which means they’ll catch you here, which means you’re going to be expelled!”

Katsuki glared at Izuku.

“You really can’t see past beyond your own damn freckled nose, can you, shitty nerd?”

Izuku blinked up at him.

“What?”

“They were headed to fucking UA. They were going to make an invasion”.

Izuku paled.

“I can’t just go back to my fucking bedroom and chill out now because there’s a chance All fucking Might will catch me here. This is a fucking villain invasion we’re talking about. We were already fucking doomed from the moment Earphone Girl went back to the surface to make that call”.

Izuku stared at him.

“Kacchan –“

“We can’t let the villains through”.

Izuku fell silent.

Just one set of footsteps echoed across the sewers.

“I’m sorry”.

Katsuki sighed.

“What *for*?”

“I don’t want you to get expelled”.

“I don’t fucking want that either”.

“But if you do this –“

Katsuki stopped on his tracks.

“Then I’ll be no fucking hero. It would be better to just hang the coat and chase another fucking career”.

Izuku stared at him.

“A hero is more than a fucking quirk, Deku”.

Izuku’s eyes widened slightly.

“What is the use of having these”, he raised his hands up, “if I cower beneath a bunch of D-listers? If I go back to my fucking room and let these assholes infiltrate UA just because of a fucking *license*?”

Izuku’s eyes were filled with emotion and determination.

“I took my fucking time, but I finally learned it”, Katsuki said before he turned on his heels and walked away.

It took Izuku a while to go back to following Katsuki, but once he did, there was a plea in his voice.

“Kacchan, I –“

“*Kaijo*!”, Uraraka’s loud scream interrupted whatever it was Deku was about to say. Simply exchanging one quick glance with one another, Katsuki and Izuku rushed forwards, running at the top of their speed towards the sound of the girl’s voice.

The moment they stepped into the fight, Katsuki had to throw himself to the floor in order to dodge a huge piece of debris that came flying in his direction, missing him by a centimeter. He barely had any time to assess the situation at hands before someone came charging at him, huge lizard-like hands trying to grab him and only failing because Deku threw himself against him and pushed Katsuki out of the way.

They looked at each other for a split second before Katsuki engaged into combat.

This part of the sewer gallery had become a true pandemonium. Katsuki was busy fighting two villains at the same time, but his mind was sharp enough to realize, through a quick assessment, that they were easily outnumbered. Uraraka was currently fighting a guy three times her size who seemed to have super-strength, whereas Todoroki was alternating between freezing whichever villains he could and burning the rest of them down.

There were at least 8 villains against three students, but, at the same time, it felt like there weren’t villains enough. Because All Might wasn’t fucking stupid, was he? Whoever gave him the information that the soul-stealing villain would be at Hosu that night must have been a person he fucking trusted with his life. And, if having the pros go to Hosu was merely a distraction, it *had* to be a convincing distraction. If the pros arrived at Hosu and found no villain there, they would become suspicious. More than that – they would realize that something was *wrong*.

Nah. This had all been carefully planned. So, half the villains probably stayed back at Hosu in order to distract the pros, and the other half had made its way to UA in order to attack the school while its guard was low. It was a fucking clever plan, if Katsuki had to admit it. He had actually been fucking lucky to choose the sewers as a route to Hosu, otherwise he would have made a fool of himself and gone after the pros for nothing, leaving the school defenseless and vulnerable.

Leaving Deku's body defenseless and vulnerable.

What wasn't adding up was how the pros had been tricked so easily into going to a fake mission. This could only mean two things: either All Might was terrible at fucking telling who he could and couldn't trust, which was improbable, or…

Someone was controlling All Might's source.

Which planted an idea in Katsuki's mind, an idea he did not like. Not one bit.

But it was balance of probability, really.

Uraraka finally managed to subdue her adversary by trapping him in the very debris he was throwing at her, which meant one of Katsuki's villains shifted their focus towards the panting girl. This left Katsuki facing only one villain, which was the lizard-looking guy, until a second and a third one appeared out of nowhere, probably having managed to escape Todoroki's ice.

Katsuki smirked viciously. They could send a fucking army at him, and he would still take them down.

Deku was clearly feeling helpless in this fight, since he couldn't really touch any of the villains and, therefore, couldn't fight them off. The only way he found to participate was to shove Katsuki, the only person he was tangible to, away from potential danger or towards a possible victory. Katsuki wanted to tell Deku to *stop fucking pushing me, I don't need your fucking help*, but there was no time. In a fight like this, where he was outnumbered and with zero backup, every single breath he wasted was dangerous and could result on a defeat.

Just as a villain with a sword instead of an arm was about to decapitate Katsuki – or try to –, Izuku kicked his friend on the knees, making him fall on his back to the floor. Katsuki felt furious, but took the opportunity to blow the villain's ass to kingdom come and dodge a second villain's attack at the same time.

"Stop fucking knocking me down!", he ended up screaming at the same time he propelled himself forwards with a careful set of controlled explosions.

"I'm just trying to help!", Deku protested.

"You fell down on your own, hero!", the villain responded, clearly thinking that Katsuki's protest had been directed towards him.

“Shut the fuck up!”, Katsuki shouted at the same time he threw himself against the man, his words directed both at Deku and at the villain. “And DIE!!!”

Todoroki came for Uraraka’s aid once he was done freezing the asses off his own adversaries. He used his left side to burn the villain who had managed to grab the girl into a chokehold. Uraraka was panting as she toppled to the floor holding her neck, but when Todoroki offered her his support, she refused it, getting back to her feet and charging at one of the three villains that were still on Katsuki. Todoroki took the hint and took the other guy fighting Katsuki, which meant there was only one left whose ass he needed to blow up.

He smirked wickedly at the remaining guy, holding his hands at his sides and making them pop with explosions. This was the last man standing for him. He had already defeated all of them. Maybe there was a chance they would actually manage to find the soul-stealing bastard and go back to UA before the pros got there and caught them red-handed, maybe there was a chance they wouldn’t actually be punished –

Before Katsuki could finish the guy down with one explosion and a scream of “DIE!!!”, a powerful wave sent the villain flying back, away from Katsuki’s explosion and colliding with a far-off column. The man fell on his face, unmoving and unconscious.

Katsuki turned his head back at the direction the wave had come from.

It was fucking Earphone Girl, with Four Eyes right behind her.

Katsuki scowled, which wiped away the triumphal smile from Jirou’s lips.

“What?”, the girl frowned, almost offended.

“Are you fucking kidding me?!”, Katsuki shouted back.

“*Seriously*, Bakugou?”

“I *had* him!”

“There’s just no *pleasing* you, is there?”, she protested as she and Iida walked into the fight, rushing to Uraraka and Todoroki’s aid. They were having a bit of trouble with the villains they were facing, which seemed to be stronger than the previous ones – which only made sense, since they were the last ones standing.

“I would have been pleased if I had killed that fucking guy!”

“You can’t kill anyone, Bakugou-kun!”, Iida protested at the same time he roundhouse kicked Uraraka’s adversary on the face using his Recipro Burst. Needless to say, the guy was immediately out of commission, and Iida simply gesticulated at Katsuki and straightened his glasses. “It goes against the heroic code of UA –“

“Yeah, yeah, fucking spare me”, Katsuki turned his back on Iida, ready to walk over to Icy Hot and defeat his villain for him, just so that he could take his victory out of his hands and have something to brag about.

Then, everything happened at once.

A deep burning pain erupted on Katsuki's back before he could take another step, as if he had just been struck down by an axe from the behind. For a moment, he genuinely thought that this was what had happened – there was no other explanation. The pain was so intense that he immediately fell on all fours to the floor, eyes wide as a soundless gasp passed his lips. The pain was so strong he couldn't breathe, couldn't think, couldn't do anything else other than endure, endure, *endure* –

"Bakugou! What happened?"

"Bakugou-kun! Are you alright?"

"Bakugou".

"Bakugou!"

"Bakugou, can you hear me? What's wrong?"

"Kacchan!"

"Bakugou!"

"Bakugou!"

"*Kacchan*!"

Katsuki swallowed past the pain and opened his eyes, which he had ended up squeezing shut due to the pain. The faces of his friends were blurry around him, staring at him with concern and with pleas on their voices, but all Katsuki could see and concentrate on was Deku.

Deku, who was on the floor. Deku, who looked horrified. Deku, who looked as if he was just as in much pain as Katsuki.

Deku, who was being dragged across the floor by an invisible rope.

Katsuki set the pain, which was *overwhelming*, aside, and forced himself to his wobbly feet. He didn't last long, and ended up falling on his knees again. It felt like he was being fucking branded, as if there was melted metal dripping down his back and making his flesh scream. But he endured it. He had to.

"Deku", he grunted past the pain, voice barely above a whisper, stumbling his way towards the boy. He couldn't stand up, but that didn't mean he had to stand still.

"Bakugou, wait!"

"What are you doing?!"

"Deku", he managed to put more energy into his voice. Deku continued to be dragged away from him by an invisible force.

“Bakugou, where are you going?”

“What’s going on?!”

All villains had been defeated. They were all fallen. Then what was –?

Katsuki saw him.

He was propped up against the wall at a far-off distance, and his face looked ten times more skeleton-like and unhealthy than Katsuki remembered it, but it was him. He had no doubt it was *him*.

It was the *fucking* soul-stealer.

“He’s resistant, this one, isn’t he?”, the man scorned past chapped lips, voice sounding weak and looking like he was about to drop dead. He had one hand stretched hand towards Deku, which seemed to be what was dragging the boy across the floor. Deku was sobbing and choking on his own spit, and it was in that moment Katsuki realized the pain he was feeling was not the result of an injury, but a reflection of Deku’s.

Fuck.

“Let go of him”, was what Katsuki managed to spit through teeth that were gritted in pain, pain, so much *pain*. What the fuck was this guy doing to Deku?

Katsuki’s brain was foggy and fuzzy from the sheer agony he was feeling, which was why it took him so long to realize that the source of his pain was coming from around the same spot as the scar on Deku’s back.

“I came such a long way to find him”, the man giggled manically, as if he couldn’t quite stop himself. Katsuki picked up his pace despite the pain and threw himself belly first on the floor, managing to grab Deku by the ankle before he could get too further away. Deku yelped in pain.

“I said to fucking *let go*!”, Katsuki took all the strength he had left to scream. He pulled Deku’s ankle, dragging the boy closer to himself.

The villain made a pulling movement with his arm, and Deku was yanked away from Katsuki’s grasp with a pained scream. Katsuki didn’t waste any time – he immediately threw himself back on all-fours and chased after Deku as fast as he could, despite the pain.

He could hear his friends saying something behind him, calling for his name, noticing the presence of a villain they hadn’t spotted before, but Katsuki couldn’t pay them any attention. Because of the unbearable pain, and because of Deku’s screams, and because Deku was being fucking snatched away from his very fucking hands and he couldn’t let *that* happen.

“He’s such a fighter”, the villain commented with something that sounded like admiration in his voice, still slowly dragging Deku across the floor towards him. Katsuki managed to grab the boy’s ankle once again, but the pain was making him weak, and Deku slipped off his fingers yet again.

“*Fuck*!”, Katsuki screamed, dragging himself across the floor as he tried to reach Deku, who was screaming and twisting and kicking his feet in an attempt to free himself from the invisible bond that was dragging him painfully.

Matte yo, Deku!

“I’ve never seen someone resist my quirk as hard as he does”, the villain continued, casual and weak. “But, again, nothing like this had ever happened to me. To think I had to come all this way just to retrieve a soul…”, he giggled again. Katsuki gritted his teeth, still fighting the pain. He was sweaty and shaking and fucking losing his mind, but he had to reach Deku, he had to, he wouldn’t be fucking defeated by a nearly dead guy –

“But it’s useless to resist. You’re mine now, boy”.

Katsuki fumed.

“You bastard! I’ll kill you!”, he screamed at the top of his lungs, trying his best to lunge at the guy.

His fucking useless friends finally stepped into the scene and rushed towards the villain in a speed Katsuki would have never been able to achieve at his current state, not with the pain, not with the weakness. He felt as if his very own soul was being drained out of his body, as if the pain he was feeling was a result of that separation. His arms were so shaky from that horrible, hurtful sensation that he ended up falling face-first to the floor, which only made him angrier, because there was no way, there was *no way* he was going to allow himself to be defeated like this. Someone tried to help him up, but he shoved the hand away and supported his own weight up with his elbows.

“It’s normal to feel this pain, Bakugou-kun”, the villain told him tauntingly, at the same time Iida and Todoroki grabbed him and pulled his weak form to his feet. That didn’t seem to stop him from ranting – in fact, that didn’t seem to bother him at all. “You weren’t born with my quirk, after all. You aren’t supposed to have a soul attached to yours”.

Todoroki shoved the villain’s hands behind his back and secured them by freezing them together. Iida continued to sustain the man’s weight up, since he looked like he was about to collapse if he didn’t have anything to support him up.

“But don’t worry”, the man smirked. “I will relieve you from this burden, now”.

Katsuki’s eyes widened in realization.

“Fucking – *stop* him – knock him *out* –“

Izuku’s piercing scream etched itself in Katsuki’s brain forevermore.

“God fucking damn it – *Deku*!!”

Katsuki all but launched himself towards the fallen boy, who was withering in pain on the floor and panting heavily. Katsuki used what was left of his strength to grab him, pulling him

closer to his chest and away from the villain, who was still being held up by Iida and Todoroki. The pair of friends was staring down at Katsuki with wide, confused eyes.

The pain on Katsuki's back was too unbearable, and he ended up collapsing to the floor again, Deku falling heavily against his chest, still panting, still shaking. Katsuki held him close and glared up at the villain – who, much to his horror, was looking stronger and healthier by the second.

Almost as if he was using Deku's lifeforce to heal himself.

"Watch out –!", Katsuki tried to warn.

The villain tore through Todoroki's ice with two powerful beams, releasing his hands and stretching his shoulders. Iida and Todoroki were sent flying from the impact, hitting the floor limply. Katsuki continued to clutch Deku to his chest protectively as the villain regain his ground and his strength with each breath he took.

Jirou tried to aim a heartbeat wave at the villain but, before she could do anything, the man struck both her and Uraraka down with a well-aimed blast.

Which meant Katsuki was the last man standing.

The villain – *Soulmonger* – took his time strolling to where Katsuki was fallen, clutching Izuku against his chest. He stopped in front of the two boys and tilted his head with interest.

"You know what", he shrugged casually. "This was all so much trouble. I don't think I really want their souls, on the top of everything I went through", he waved a hand and, at the same time, Iida, Todoroki, Uraraka and Jirou gasped soundly. They did not regain consciousness. "UA students are just a mess to handle".

He crouched down, trying to run a finger across Izuku's cheek. Katsuki pulled the boy closer to himself, trying to shield him from the villain the best he could despite the pain and the weakness he was feeling. He was in such agony that he had started to shake, cold sweat erupting on his forehead.

"But this one", the villain smirked evilly, looking at Deku and untroubled by Katsuki's attempts to cradle the boy. "This one is a matter of honor. I almost died because of him".

"K-Kacchan", Izuku sobbed, his fingers clinging to Katsuki's shirt as if it was a lifeline. He sounded like he was in terrible pain – a pain even worse than Katsuki's. "K-Kacchan, please… D-Don't…"

"Calm *down*, Deku", Katsuki ordered through gritted teeth, ignoring his own gut-wrenching pain and ending up sounding a lot more aggressive than he had intended.

Izuku continued to tug at his shirt, as if trying to call his attention.

Katsuki turned his head to look at Deku. His eyes were wide, teary and afraid.

"D-Don't let go", Izuku pleaded. "P-Please, don't let g-go".

I was completely alone. I think I got nervous because of this. I mean, you're the only one who can see me and who can talk to me, and if you stopped doing that… What would I be? Just a ghost, stuck in the void, screaming without being heard, existing without being seen. I think I'm scared of being stuck like this forever, and… I think I'm scared I'll end up all alone. Away from my body, from everyone I love… A-Away from you.

Katsuki bit his lower lip, staring down at Deku and making sure to put as much confidence in his eyes as he could.

"I'm not letting go".

"Promise him, *hero*", the villain chuckled with humor, watching the exchange and taking pleasure on the boys' suffering. "Promise your friend you are not letting go of him".

Katsuki glared up at the man with the fury of a thousand suns, raising one threatening, smoking hand at him.

"Don't fucking *tell me* what to do, you bastard".

The villain smirked.

Then, before Katsuki could do anything, before he could set off any explosions, the villain raised one hand and snapped his fingers.

The pain on Katsuki's back was instantly gone.

He gasped in surprise at the sudden lack of agony, toppling to the side. It was relieving, yes, but deep down, Katsuki knew it could only mean one thing. One thing that wasn't relieving at all.

"I think I'll see you around, sometime", the villain said as he got back to his feet and walked away into the tunnel, fully recovered from his previous weakness. "But I'd rather not, really".

The villain was walking slowly, as if he was no longer in a hurry. As if he had all the time in the world.

As if he knew Katsuki wouldn't come after him.

Izuku sobbed pitifully on his chest before Katsuki could say or do anything else.

"Kacchan… K-Kacchan…"

You're the only one who can see me and who can talk to me, and if you stopped doing that… What would I be?

"I'm here".

Just a ghost

"Kacchan, p-please, don't let… don't let go –"

stuck in the void

“What did I *fucking* tell you? I’m not letting go, Deku. I’ve fucking got you. Ok? I’ve got you, just – just *calm the hell down*”.

screaming without being heard

“P-Please –“

existing without being seen

“I’m not letting go. I’m here. I’ve got you”.

I’m scared I’ll end up all alone

“Kacchan…”

“Don’t you fucking trust me, shitty nerd? Didn’t I just tell you I’m not letting go?”

“P-Please… Oh my god, my mom… My mom, K-Kacchan –“

“Your mom is fine. I promise you she’s fine, nerd”.

Away from my body, from everyone I love

“P-Please… It… It hurts…”

“I know it fucking hurts”.

“Y-You can feel it?”

Katsuki pursed his lips. Izuku was already terrified and in pain. He didn’t think telling the nerd he could no longer feel his pain would do wonders for his nerves.

But Katsuki wasn’t a liar. If there was something he really valued, it was honesty.

But he was scared. For the first time in a long fucking while, and possibly for one of the first times ever, he was fucking terrified. And the villain was getting further and further away.

As much as he wanted to comfort Deku, he also wanted to be honest with him. He was always honest with shitty Deku, he had *always* been.

“I can’t. Not anymore”.

Izuku’s glassy eyes focused on him, several tears escaping through the corners. He looked shocked, and terrified, and suddenly –

Determined.

He knew what Katsuki not feeling his pain meant.

Izuku immediately raised a shaking hand to his mop of a hair, grabbed a lock of his green curls, yanked it off his head and immediately shoved it into Katsuki's mouth.

Or he *would* have shoved it into Katsuki's mouth, if his soul hadn't chosen that exact fucking moment to become fucking *intangible* again.

Deku phased through Katsuki's arms, and chest, and body.

Katsuki could no longer touch him.

"No", Izuku sobbed, staring at his own hands. He desperately tried to grab Katsuki, to hold him, to cling to him, but it was useless – he was like a ghost. A real fucking ghost, this time. "No, no, no, n-no, please, Kacchan, no –"

Away from you

"Deku", Katsuki whispered, eyes wide, lips parted, horrified. He was kneeling on the floor, the transparent Izuku lying in front of him on the floor. Katsuki tried to hold a hand to his shoulder, but it phased through him. If anything, Katsuki could already see the floor beneath Deku's disappearing form.

Because that was what he was doing. He was fucking *disappearing*.

The villain had detached Deku's soul from Katsuki and had reclaimed it as his own.

Worst case scenario. A scenario he hadn't even considered.

Katsuki stared down at Izuku with wide, horrified eyes, teeth gritted.

There was nothing he could say.

"Kacchan", Izuku was sobbing desperately, trying to hold Katsuki and failing. He was weak, still affected by the pain of his separation from Katsuki's soul. His fingers just phased through him as if he was a hologram . "Kacchan, p-please!"

Katsuki stared at him. He could barely see Izuku now.

He didn't know what to do or say.

Worst case scenario.

"K-Kacchan!"

Katsuki continued to stare at him in shock, eyes wide.

"K-K-Ka...cchan..."

He should probably do something.

Matte yo, Kacchan!

“Deku –”

Izuku disappeared.

Katsuki could no longer touch him, or see him, or hear him.

He was gone.

He was fucking gone.

Katsuki stared at the place where Izuku had been just a second ago, and where now there was nothing. He stared at his own hands, which were empty. He stared off at the tunnel, in the direction where the villain had disappeared.

His friends were starting to wake up from the villain’s attack, disoriented and confused.

The villain couldn’t have gotten far. He was still recovering. He couldn’t have gotten far.

Katsuki got to his feet.

His legs were shaking, and he had to support himself against the wall for a moment. He wasn’t sure the aftershock of the pain he had felt was the only factor that caused that.

“B-Bakugou? What happened?”

Katsuki walked past Jirou, who was still on the floor, his eyes focused on the dark tunnel in front of him. His face was impassive.

“Where are you going? What happened?”

He kept on limping.

“Where is that guy? Did he hurt you?”

“Did he attack us? I don’t remember”.

“What’s going on?”

“Bakugou?”

“Bakugou!”

“Bakugou”.

Katsuki turned to look at Icy Hot. He was the only one who had successfully gotten to his feet.

Katsuki didn’t know what emotion he was showing in his crimson eyes.

“Make an ice wall”.

Todoroki stared at him. If Katsuki didn't know him better, he would have sworn there was fear in the Half'n'Half multicolored eyes.

"What for?"

Katsuki turned around and continued walking.

"Bakugou, *wait*!"

They were trying to follow him. Katsuki didn't stop. If anything, he picked up his pace.

"Bakugou, where are you going?"

"Bakugou-kun, tell us what happened!"

"Bakugou –"

He saw the distant shadow of the villain, walking off into the tunnel slowly and leisurely, as if he was just going home after a merry stroll at the mall.

As if Katsuki would fucking let him do that.

As if Katsuki would fucking stand aside and do nothing.

As if Katsuki would allow him to steal Deku from him and get away with it.

His legs were shaking. His arms were shaking. The phantom of the terrible pain he had felt was still resonating across him.

It had also made him sweat.

It had made him sweat a whole fucking lot.

Katsuki was close enough to the villain who had stolen Deku away.

The villain who had hurt Deku.

They were in a closed environment, but the sewer gallery was tall enough. Actually, it was pretty fucking tall. The walls were thick, and so were the columns.

They would have to resist.

He couldn't let this guy just walk away.

He mustered all the strength he had left.

"Howitzer –"

A series of gasps.

"Oh my god!"

“Todoroki!”

“Bakugou, no –!”

“ – Impacto!”

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He was on his knees, staring at his own hands with wide, fixed eyes that searched desperately for something that wasn’t there.

His ears were still ringing from the explosions he had produced himself. The feeling wasn’t uncommon – whenever he pushed himself too far or recurred to attacks such as the howitzer, it would take some time for his ears to get back to normal. He had never told anyone, but he thought he was starting to get tinnitus. Sometimes, the ringing in his ears was too constant or too loud for him not to worry – but he would rather lose his hearing than to stop using his quirk.

Right now, he couldn’t hear anything from his right ear.

He took a shaky hand to it, and his fingertips came back covered in blood.

Well.

He went back to staring at his hands, one of which was now bloodied.

“ “

A large hand grabbed his shoulder and he startled, not having heard or sensed any movement from behind him in his shock. His immediate response was to aim an explosion at whoever was grabbing him, which he did, but it had no effect – All Might, however quirkless he was

now, was still strong enough to endure one of Katsuki's weak attacks. He had used up all of his sweat by now. Whatever explosions he could produce at this point, after pushing himself to his limit, would be too weak to harm even a child.

His hands hurt. His shoulders ached. His back ached. His chest and his ribs ached, even though he had received no sort of blow in those particular places.

He couldn't breathe, suddenly. And as All Might stared down at him with questioning eyes, searching eyes, eyes that were begging for some sort of answer or confirmation, all Katsuki could do was swallow an ugly sob that was threatening to rise to his throat and scrunch his face up in an ugly grimace, fighting back the tears that were already pooling in his crimson, ever angry eyes.

“ “

He hated crying. He rarely ever cried. And whenever he did, it was due to strong, alien emotion. Defeat, for when Deku beat him in the training exercise. Guilt, for when he caused the end of a person he admired and loved, such as All Might.

Right at that moment, Katsuki was feeling both things. Defeat and guilt, throbbing inside his heart like a painful reminder of his failure and his loss.

He broke down into sobs.

It was ok. His friends weren't there. No one could see him other than All Might, and All Might had been one of the only two people who had ever seen him cry.

The other person was Deku.

All Might pulled his limp, silently sobbing form into a tight hug. Katsuki could tell he was crying, too, not from the sound of it but from the movement of his chest, and found that there was nothing, absolutely nothing he could say.

Chapter End Notes

I was gonna name this chapter "How To Disappear Completely" because I'm a slut for Radiohead, but that would just be giving the plot away, amirite?
I hope you guys don't hate me. I did tell you the angst was coming.
Also if anything about this chapter feels weird (typos, plotholes, things that don't make sense etc) it's probably because I wrote it AND revised it while dealing with a fucked up pharyngitis and a 39ºC fever (which converts 102,2ºF, apparently). YES, I'm taking care of myself, YES, I'm feeling better. Don't you guys worry, ok? I'm gonna be just fine <3
ALSO also, as some of you probably found out based on my work list, I started out on ao3 by writing to the Les Mis fandom, so of course I had to shove a sewer scene somewhere in my story.
Anyway. Comments? Suggestions? Name-calling? Infinite hatred for me? It's all

welcome here. Let me know what you guys think, I hope I didn't exaggerate too much! (Also don't worry this is NOT a deathfic and c'mon. Everything's gonna be fine, eventually)

Chapter 15: O Gosto da Raiva

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The first thing he noticed upon waking up was that he couldn't remember having fallen asleep.

The second thing he noticed was that his mom was talking above him, but he couldn't hear the sound of her voice.

Her furious face was coming in and out of focus, her mouth opening and closing and curling to form words, but all Katsuki could hear was a dull, constant ringing that was driving him fucking insane. Which was why he ended up blurting out:

"*Haah*?"

And his eyes widened when he didn't hear the sound of his own voice.

"What the *fuck*?!", he exclaimed, trying to take a hand to his ear and failing. Tilting his head downwards to see what was keeping him from moving, Katsuki found himself even more shocked when he realized his right hand was secured closely to his chest by a cast. His mom was moving beside him, still saying something and looking angry that Katsuki wasn't answering her.

He stared up at her. Her lips were still moving and she was waving her hands around as if about to smack him in rage. In fact, she looked like she was screaming.

And Katsuki still couldn't hear it.

"What?", he asked, because surely his shitty mom was the one to blame for him not being able to hear her. She needed to speak up.

She paused, staring at him with a weird expression on her face. Katsuki hated that look.

"Can you speak the fuck up? I can't fucking hear you".

She stared at him, frowning.

" ?"

"What?"

" ".

Katsuki's heart sped up. What the fuck was going on?

" !"

“I can’t – I can’t *hear* you”, he ended up saying, horrified. His mom’s eyes widened. “What the fuck. What the fucking fuck. What the – what the *fuck*”, he breathed, wriggling on the bed and trying to free his left hand. He managed to take it out from beneath the blanket and brought it up to his ear despite the IV that was sticking out of it, but his fingers came back clean. He stared up at his mom, who was still saying something, who was still trying to talk to him, but nothing other than the ringing made its way to his ears.

And yeah, Katsuki wasn’t a person who felt fucking scared easily. He laughed in the face of adversity. But *this*? He didn’t know how to handle this. Most of all, he didn’t feel like he was in the state of handling something like this.

Because there was something nagging at his brain, a memory of some sorts, something urgent… Something troubling. Something that he couldn’t remember, and that he felt like he didn’t want to remember. But he couldn’t tell what it was for the life of him.

Was he deaf? Had he lost his fucking hearing?

He tried to push himself into a sitting position, but as soon as he moved the world around him began to spin and turn and nothing made sense anymore.

The second time he woke up, he saw the wrinkly face of Recovery Girl hovering above him.

“Bakugou-kun”, she said. “Can you hear me?”

Katsuki stared at her.

“Yeah”.

She nodded, and walked out of his field of vision.

“Hey, wait”, he called after her, a bit angry. What kind of fucking doctor just walked out on a patient who had just woken up like that?

“I’m still here. I’m going to take your chart”.

“What?”

She reappeared into his field of vision holding a tablet.

“I was just taking your chart”, she explained. Katsuki frowned at her.

“What the fuck happe–“

“I am sure you must have a lot of questions, young man. We’ll go over them in a moment. First, I need to examine you”.

Katsuki glared at her. Why was she speaking in such a low tone?

She shone a light over his eyes without warning, making him flinch. Analyzing his pupils for a moment and apparently feeling satisfied with the result, she tilted his head to the side abruptly and began to check his left ear.

Katsuki couldn’t see what she was doing, and she didn’t say anything. A few moments later, she moved on to the right ear, and after examining it as well, she stepped back.

“Any pain?”

Katsuki frowned, trying to do a mental assessment of his own body. He couldn’t feel any immediate pain – just a dull throbbing of his right shoulder and the beginnings of a headache.

“My shoulder is throbbing”, he settled for saying. Recovery Girl hummed low and nodded, typing something down on Katsuki’s chart without looking at him.

“I’ll see what I can do about that”, she announced matter-of-factly before turning on her heels and walking away again.

Katsuki stayed where he was, looking around idly. He couldn’t really remember what he had done in order to get himself in the fucking infirmary, but from the state of his shoulder it must have been something fucking bad. If anything, he *hoped* it had been something fucking bad – he would hate to be stuck there with Recovery Girl over something as ridiculous as passing out from exhaustion because of shitty Deku.

Speaking of which, the nerd was uncharacteristically fucking silent. Katsuki looked around, searching for him, but didn’t find him anywhere. Which was weird, frankly. Shitty Deku never left his side. Had the asshole snuck out to catch a look on his body again, since they were at the infirmary? Or had he fallen asleep on the floor in order not to disrupt Katsuki while he recovered from whatever this was?

It would be just like shitty Deku to do that. Sleep on the cold, hard, shitty floor just so that Katsuki could get his proper rest on the bed like the self-sacrificing asshole he was. He shifted, angrily, trying to look over to the floor and hoping to find the asshat all curled up there.

Deku wasn’t there.

Katsuki frowned. He shifted to his other side, his injured right side. It was a bit difficult because of his arm, but he managed it. Deku wasn’t there, either.

Weird. He was probably checking on his body, then, since they were at the infirmary. He would probably be back any minute now.

Katsuki relaxed and lied back on the bed, deciding he would take this rare Deku-free moment to enjoy the peace and the quiet without the nerd rambling on his ears.

He couldn't even remember what had been the last time he was all alone. Recovery Girl was gone, Deku was out for a stroll, and he… He was all by himself in the quiet of the infirmary room. He had no reasons to complain, really, if not for the slightly increasing pain on his shoulder and arm. But other than that? No reasons to complain. At all. He could definitely fucking use some alone time, some privacy, some silence.

Recovery Girl came back and injected something into his IV drip – which Katsuki didn't even realize he had been wearing until he saw the tiny woman accessing it beside his bed. He stared at her, then at the plastic tube making its way to his left hand, then at the purple, abused skin around the needle. He frowned.

If his hand was this bruised… How long had he been there?

"This should dull your pain in a few minutes", Recovery Girl told him, taking hold of her chart and staring at Katsuki. "I've already healed you in the best way I could without taking up all of your stamina, so there isn't much more I can do for you at the moment. You need to rest and give yourself some time to heal".

Katsuki stared at her, waiting for further explanations. None came.

"Heal from what?", he asked, annoyed. What was it that he had to heal from that would keep him in this fucking hospital bed? If there wasn't anything urgent about his situation, he'd rather go back to his fucking bedroom, even if that meant breaking the pattern of silence and taking shitty Deku along with him. He'd much rather be in his room with Deku than be on his own at this damn infirmary.

Recovery Girl sighed. Katsuki realized she looked grievous.

"Though your concussion is better, I still want to keep you under observation for another night. Your shoulder should be fully healed by tomorrow morning, but I don't want to risk you putting weight on it if I let you go wandering about. Plus…", she hesitated, not meeting Katsuki's eyes. "You're not allowed into any other UA buildings except for the infirmary until the trial, so there's really no point getting out of here anyway. And, since your aid is arriving tomorrow, there's no reason why you should head home, either".

Katsuki blinked blankly at her.

"What the fuck are you talking about?"

Recovery Girl sighed.

"Bakugou-kun, I understand your situation, but that does not make room for using such a foul language at my –"

"Can you speak the hell up? I can barely hear you", he interrupted her, annoyed by the low tone she had been using so far. From what Katsuki could see, there was no fucking one else at

the infirmary with them – no patients, no sleeping people, no *one* –, so who was she keeping her voice down for?

Recovery Girl lowered her head and sighed, as if she had been through that exact conversation a hundred times over. Katsuki glared at her.

"*Shonen*… What is the last thing you remember?", she settled for asking, which quite frankly pissed Katsuki off, because he didn't know the answer to that, and he hated not knowing things. He hated that he was stuck in this goddamn fucking infirmary, and that he didn't know what happened to him, and that shitty fucking Deku had decided to be a useless piece of shit as usual and go for a damn stroll instead of staying there and telling him what had gotten him there in the first place. He bet it had to do with the nerd.

Most of all, he hated that he sort of kind of wished damn Deku was there in the first place, which was against every single thing he believed in. *And* which was making him even grumpier than usual.

"I don't know", was Katsuki's annoyed, sincere response. "I don't even know why I'm here in the first damn place".

Recovery Girl looked at him for long moments, studying him. Then, she sat down at the edge of his bed, placed his chart carefully beside her on the mattress, and crossed her hands on her lap.

"Other than a dislocated shoulder and a minor concussion, you have sustained another type of injury", she began, looking very serious. "Last night, you snuck out of school through the sewers and encountered several villains on your way. One of them was the villain whose quirk detached Young Midoriya's soul from his body".

Katsuki stared at her.

"You used your Howitzer move to attack him. *In* a closed environment. *With* a lot of acoustic reverberation due to the architectural structure of the sewer gallery".

Katsuki stared at her.

"Evidently, the structural damage you caused to the sewers wasn't the only consequence of your actions. From what I could tell so far, you have suffered an irreversible loss of hearing on your right ear, and a temporary one on your left. It should make a full recovery in a couple of days, but I'm afraid you will have to wear a hearing aid on your right ear for the rest of your life".

Katsuki stared at her.

Recovery Girl stared at him.

"The UA Board will have a meeting where we will determine whether or not you should face expulsion for your actions. They are waiting until you are cleared out so you can participate

on your own trial and defend yourself but, until then, you no longer have clearance to roam school grounds".

Katsuki stared at her.

He just… stared.

"Do you have any questions?"

Katsuki's left hand tightened into a fist.

"Please, do not remove your IV again".

"What about Deku?"

"Bakugou-kun –"

"And the villain who did this shit? Where is he? Did you guys capture him?"

"Yes, he was captured. I barely managed to keep him alive –"

"Then why, in fuck's name, am *I* the one facing trial?", Katsuki interrupted angrily. "I captured the jerk for you, and I'm getting fucking punished for it? How does that make any goddamn sense?"

"Bakugou-kun, you should settle back down –"

"And where the fuck is Deku, anyway? Huh? You should go to the fucker's bedroom and tell his shitty soul to get its ass back here because he's got some damn explaining to do –"

"Bakugou *shonen*!", Recovery Girl interrupted him angrily, raising her voice. "Stop yelling at my infirmary and calm down before I knock you out again!"

Katsuki stared at her with anger, scowling and flaring his nostrils.

"I wasn't fucking yelling –"

"You can't tell because your hearing is impaired, but your voice is louder than usual", Recovery Girl pointed out. "Making such a scene when you're already in trouble won't do you any favors, so try to calm down and rest. If you are better by tomorrow morning, we'll see what we can do about the trial".

Katsuki's lips formed a thin, displeased line. He would have felt embarrassed, if he was a different person – he really couldn't tell whether his voice was too loud or not. Instead, he just stayed where he was, glaring at Recovery Girl as if she had personally offended him. The woman stood up from the bed and grabbed her chart, giving Katsuki an almost sad look.

"I have no idea what you are going through, Bakugou-kun, but you need to be careful from now on if you plan on sticking to the hero career", she said. "I'm not the best person for you

to have this conversation with, but it would be for the best if you learned how to control yourself better".

"The fuck?", Katsuki protested, angry. "I can control myself just *fine*".

Recovery Girl stared at him with melancholy.

"The villain was half-dead when he got here. The damage to your right ear became irreversible because I spent too much time trying to keep him from dying, rather than tending to you right away. He is alive and in a secure location right now, but this could have easily turned into an even bigger tragedy".

Katsuki stared at her.

She sighed and grabbed her cane.

"I need to go, now. I shouldn't even have to say that you are not, under any circumstances, to leave this bed or this room. If you need anything, press the call button and I will come for you".

She turned on her heels. She was almost stepping out of the infirmary when Katsuki called after her.

"Oi".

Recovery Girl looked at him over her shoulder.

"If you pass by Deku's room, can you tell the asshole to get over here? I know you can't see him and shit, but he can hear you just fine. I just want to ask him about some stuff".

Recovery Girl stared at him, and then said something.

She was standing too far away for Katsuki to be able to hear her response, and he didn't want to look like a fucking idiot by asking her to repeat herself yet again. So he simply nodded at whatever she had just told him and watched as she left, leaving him alone to his thoughts.

She must have also drugged him through his IV, because he started feeling dizzy and sleepy not so soon after she was gone – probably a failsafe to keep him from trying to sneak out. In fact, his mind became so addled that he couldn't even try to make a review of everything Recovery Girl had just told him, or try to remember about the villains and the sewers in the first place. His brain was a mess of memories, thoughts and flashes that seemed out of order – he tried to make himself worry about the trial and the expulsion, but on that moment, those were only words, lexemes, pieces of sounds and phonemes detached from any sort of higher meaning... Words that didn't carry the weight, the burden or the absolute dread that they should have.

Just words, floating around in his drugged brain and mixing together with each other…

Katsuki ended up falling asleep, waiting for Deku to show up.

“How does that feel?”

“Weird”.

“But can you hear me?”

“Unfortunately”.

“Don’t be like that”.

“Tch”.

A pause.

“Your mom asked me to tell you she’s sorry for getting herself banned from the infirmary”.

Katsuki stared at him.

“She was banned?”

“Yes… I don’t expect you to remember that”.

“I was awake?”

“Yes”.

A pregnant pause.

“I don’t remember it”.

“That’s ok, Katsuki. You were in a lot of meds”.

“Actually, it fucking isn’t”.

“Language”.

“Piss *off*”.

“*Katsuki*”.

“Fine”.

A sigh.

“It’s normal that you don’t remember. You were suffering from a concussion. And, besides that, after such a traumatic event…”

Katsuki scowled at him.

“Why would it be *traumatic*?”

Masaru tilted his head to the side.

“Katsuki. You *lost your hearing*”.

“Yeah, in *one* ear. And that’s what I’ve got the fucking aid for. I’m not traumatized or anything”.

“But you should be”.

“Eh?”

“It’s not normal to go through everything that you did and come out unshaken. You can take your time to mourn”.

Katsuki scoffed.

“To mourn *what*? I’ve already told you I’ve got the fucking aid. I can hear you just fine. I ain’t gonna sit around weeping and moping because of my lost hearing when I *can*, in fact, fucking hear”.

Masaru stared at Katsuki with the saddest look ever.

“And… What about your friend?”

Katsuki frowned.

“What friend?”

“Midoriya. Izuku Midoriya”.

Katsuki scoffed.

“He’ll come back anytime, now. He’s probably just weeping and dropping snot all over his shitty body over there at his bedroom like the crybaby he is”.

Masaru stared at him for what felt like an eternity, the weight of all the words he couldn’t say lingering in the air.

“What?”

“Katsuki… You don’t remember?”

“Remember *what*?”

“You and Midoriya, you…”, he hesitated. “You were separated. The villain separated him from you at the sewers”.

Don’t let go

Kacchan, please

“At least that is what All Might told us. He was the first pro to arrive at the scene”.

Matte yo, Kacchan

“So… I suppose that means you are no longer able to see him. That’s – That’s what All Might told us, anyway”.

Katsuki stared straight ahead, glaring, angry.

If his glare could set things on fire, his blanket would be in flames.

“And the villain?”, he asked through gritted teeth.

“Sorry?”

“The villain. Recovery Girl said he was in a bad shape”.

“Oh, well… I don’t know. They aren’t telling anyone anything about it. At least – I don’t think I have the clearance to know that”.

“Huh”.

Masaru stared at his son.

“Are you ok?”

Katsuki stared at him with a scowl.

“Why the fuck wouldn’t I be?”

His father sighed, almost impatient, lowering his head and shaking it.

“Katsuki –“

“I’m *fine*”.

“What?”

“I said I’m fine”.

A pause.

“You’re not, son”.

“How the fuck would you know?”

“*Stop cussing*. And I know because I’m your dad”.

“That doesn’t mean anything”.

Another pause. Masaru looked hurt.

Katsuki glared at him. *Oversensitive fuck*, just like someone he knew.

“You don’t know how I’m feeling just because you’re my dad. You have *no* idea what I’m feeling”, he explained.

No one other than Deku has any idea. He was the one who could feel what I feel. He was the one who…

Well.

Masaru gave him the saddest look in the world.

“Tell me…”, Masaru hesitated, sighing again and allowing his shoulders to slump. He looked helpless, like he was desperate to help his son but had no idea how. “Tell me what I can do”.

“Nothing”.

“There must be something –“

“I’m *fine*. You don’t have to do anything because I’m *fine*”.

Masaru stared at him. Katsuki looked away, grumpy.

“No way in hell I’m gonna be all upset just because of shitty fucking *Deku*”.

His father sort of gave up after that.

“I think it’s not necessary to tell you that you should get a hold of yourself”.

Katsuki glared at Aizawa sensei, arms crossed above his chest. Recovery Girl had removed his cast earlier that morning.

“You’re on thin ice here, Bakugou. Any misbehavior will result on expulsion”.

He looked away and stared straight ahead, not offering any sort of response. He could see, from the corner of his eye, that Aizawa sensei was still there, staring at him, waiting for something.

“Don’t lose your temper”, he settled for saying, a final warning, before he turned around and left, heading for the UA Board desk.

“The student Bakugou Katsuki left the school dormitory after curfew, attempted to exit school grounds with no clearance or direct permission from a teacher, invaded the sewer system without permission, and engaged in direct combat with a group of villains with no license or special clearance”.

Katsuki continued to stare straight ahead.

“Prototypically, just *one* of these actions alone would be enough to justify an expulsion from this school”.

“Principal –“, All Might tried to intervene.

“However”, Principal Nezu continued, ignoring the symbol of peace, “these are no ordinary circumstances. In fact, nothing about these circumstances is ordinary”.

The room was silent.

“This is a student who has endured a month of overwhelming consequences from a villain’s quirk. The responsibility for his actions is something that does not belong only to him”.

Katsuki stared at the principal.

“Still”, Nezu continued. “We cannot overlook the fact that young Bakugou broke several rules and almost killed his opponent in an unauthorized combat. These are not heroic actions, as you’ll all have to agree. The villain whose quirk affected both young Bakugou and young Midoriya is barely recovering from the injuries he has sustained from young Bakugou’s attack. That attack did not bear heroic intentions at heart, and it went directly against what we teach and believe in here at this school”.

“Principal, if I may –“, All Might tried to intervene again, but Nezu raised one paw at him.

“Finally”, he concluded. “We cannot deny, however wrong and misplaced young Bakugou’s actions were, that, had it not been for him, we would not have captured the malefactor who could have taken not one, but several lives. We, as a school and as pro heroes, have failed to do something that a 15-year-old boy in training succeeded in doing, however wrongfully. Because of this, and because of our repeated failures that led young Bakugou towards drastic measures, we, as heroes and as teachers, owe this boy a second chance to prove that he can become a professional – *with* the proper guidance”.

The room was silent again.

“My proposal is as it follows: young Bakugou will remain a student of UA and will not face expulsion, under the strict and sole circumstance that he inexcusably attends to scheduled anger-management therapy sessions offered by this school under no fee, until he receives proper medical clearance from his assigned therapist”.

Katsuki stared at him. Everyone stared at Katsuki.

“The board will discuss this decision and reconvene briefly once we have reached an agreement”.

All the teachers and board members stood up, heading to a small door at the corner of the room. The only one who hesitated before entering and looked back was All Might.

Katsuki stayed where he was. He knew his father was sitting somewhere behind him, watching him. He didn’t know if his mom was there too. He didn’t have the heart to turn and see it for himself.

He just sat there, waiting for those people to return.

Those people who were talking about him inside that room.

Those people who were currently deciding his fate.

Those people who thought he needed some sort of shitty anger therapy for some reason.

Don’t lose your temper. Don’t lose your temper. Don’t lose your temper.

Aizawa sensei said anything I do could result on expulsion, and I don’t want to be fucking expelled. I want to be a hero. I want to be a fucking hero, so I gotta keep it cool. I gotta go to this shitty therapy, if that’s what it takes for me to get a license.

I just want to be a hero. That’s all that matters. Being a fucking hero, and getting a fucking license, being a fucking pro. So I gotta keep it cool. I can’t lose my temper.

The board returned after what felt like an eternity with an answer.

There was no way out of it – Katsuki would lose, no matter what response they gave him.

“What happened to him?”

All Might gave him a sigh and a grim expression.

“We can’t tell. We are still waiting for the villain to wake up”.

Katsuki’s lips formed a thin, displeased line.

“And if he doesn’t?”

All Might stared at him.

“And if the guy doesn’t fucking wake up and the deadline ends?”

All Might didn’t say or do anything other than squeezing Katsuki’s shoulder.

He tried really hard not to dwell on the fact that, if the villain didn’t wake up in time because of his blow, because of his attack, because of his *quirk*, then he would have Deku’s blood on his hands as much as the unconscious fucker.

“Bakugou?!”

He kept on walking.

“Hey. Hey, hold up, man! How did the trial go? How are you? No one’s telling us anything!”

“Yeah, wait up, man! Talk to us! What happened? How is Midoriya? What happened at the trial?”

“Hey, Bakugou! What happened to you? Hey!”

“What’s that in his ear?”

“Dude, I’m serious, I’m worried about you, I need you to talk to – Bakugou! Wait, holy shit, man, just wait – No, don’t close the –!”

He slammed the door on Kirishima’s face.

He removed his shoes, removed his pants, and flopped down on his bed, throwing his arm above his face and burying his eyes between the crook of his forearm.

He breathed in. Breathed out. In again. Out again.

Kirishima knocked on the door.

“Hey, man. I know you need some space, but I’m really worried right now. Please just tell me you’re ok?”

Katsuki sighed.

“I’m ok”.

There was silence for around five blissful seconds.

“Ok, uh… Do you… Do you want to talk about what happened?”

Katsuki was silent.

“I mean, there’s a lot of rumor going around and Uraraka, Iida and Todoroki have been really quiet about everything, and you’ve been gone for two days and no one knew how you were and Recovery Girl said we couldn’t see you until your trial was over, and I’ve been freaking out, man, I’ve been really… I mean…”

A pause.

It lasted longer than usual.

“Why didn’t you call me, man?”

Kirishima sounded upset. Disappointed, even.

Katsuki removed his hearing aid with a little less practice than he would have enjoyed and turned on his side, deciding he could use some sleep.

He ran into Uraraka at the kitchen.

“Bakugou”, she called. There was a bandage on her face and on her forearm.

Huh. She had stopped using the “kun”.

He didn’t say anything.

“Bakugou”, she insisted, sounding worried. “Are you ok?”

He opened the fridge. No apples. He sighed, frustrated. He had forgotten to take fucking apples to his room, and now there were none anywhere. He crouched down, looking for another fruit.

“No one let us see you”, she continued. “Or told us what happened. Are you ok? Do you know anything?”

He found a mango and decided that would have to do. Not his go-to fruit, but fruit nonetheless. He grabbed it, closed the fridge, and turned on his heels, ready to leave.

She grabbed him by the wrist.

If looks could kill, she would have been obliterated by Katsuki’s glare.

“Do you know what happened to Deku-kun?”

Katsuki glared at her.

“No”.

He yanked his wrist away from her grasp and went back to his room.

He left early, as usual.

He strolled by himself, took in the cool breeze against his face, made his way to the classroom. Stepped in, took his seat, opened his notebook, ignored any and all attempts to talk to him.

Watched class, walked out, had lunch, went back to class.

Went to his room.

Lied on his bed.

Tried not to think about the fact that there were only two days left.

He stood up, grabbed a bunch of pillows. Arranged them neatly in the middle of his bed. Formed a pillow fort.

“If your creepy ghost ass is still around, I don’t want you to fucking think you can grope me in my sleep just because I can’t see you”.

He lied on his bed again, turning his back to the pillow fort.

“Stupid son of a bitch”.

He thought about going back to the med bay, about trying to see Deku. He didn’t know how he was. He didn’t know what had happened to the nerd. He didn’t ask, and no one bothered telling him. He didn’t try to go see him, and no one asked him to. He had moved on as if nothing ever happened in the first place, and no one tried to hold him back.

He longed to go there. But what would he do? What would he say?

(There wasn’t even enough time for him to go, because he had the fucking first therapy session in an hour, which barely left him enough time for a nap…)

He had captured the guy who fucked Deku up, but, because of him, there was a chance Deku would die. Because he fucked the guy up, because he almost killed him.

Deku could die. And Katsuki couldn’t even try to go visit him. Couldn’t even bother.

This is your fault. And you’re not even sorry, are you?

He looked above his shoulder, beyond the pillow fort. There was no one there.

He went to sleep.

“Hi. I’m Doctor Matsuo”.

Silence.

“How are you today, Bakugou-kun?”

Katsuki stared at her.

“Fine”.

She smiled, crossing her legs.

“That’s good to hear”, she commented, scribbling something down on her notebook. Katsuki’s primordial urge was to yell at her and demand to know what she was writing about him, but he knew better than to do that.

He sat uncomfortably on the chair, staring at her office.

It looked nice. Minimalistic. Only essential stuff, like a working desk, a sofa, for the patients, an armchair, for her. A tiny table beside her armchair. A minifridge. A painting, right above the armchair, depicting dead nature. A vase plant, sitting by the window, pretty much alive. The view was nice.

Katsuki could see how the day outside was sunny, but not too hot. The breeze was cold, and there were clouds in the sky. Everything was calm and silent.

All he could hear was the sound of the leaves when the wind hit them.

“You can relax”, Doctor Matsuo said, setting her pen down and offering him a polite smile. “This is your very first appointment, so it’s natural to feel a bit uncomfortable. I don’t plan on getting started right away today – just on getting to know you a little before we properly begin our sessions. Why don’t you tell me a bit about yourself?”

Katsuki glared at her.

He said nothing.

She offered him another encouraging smile, picking her pen up again and taking more notes. She didn’t seem bothered or surprised by his reaction.

“I see. So your full name is Katsuki Bakugou, right? Is it ok if I call you Katsuki?”

“No”.

“That’s fine”, she smiled again. “So, Bakugou-kun. I understand the circumstances that sent you to me, but I think it would be better if you told me the story yourself. Why don’t you explain to me your point of view?”

Katsuki stared at her in silence. The clock was ticking.

She stared back at him.

Silence stretched in the room.

Katsuki said nothing.

“All right. How about this – what subject would you like to talk about?”

He stared out the window.

“None”.

“And why is that?”

“Because I don’t want to be here”.

“Why not?”

“Because it’s fucking annoying and I don’t need it”.

“I see. And you’re only here because, if you don’t attend, you’ll get expelled from UA, right?”

“Yeah”.

“And if you’ll get expelled, you won’t be able to become a pro hero”.

Katsuki squinted at her, angry.

He did not respond.

“Why don’t you tell me why being a hero matters so much to you?”

“Why don’t you fuck off?”

She put her pen down again. She didn’t look offended.

“Because I care about you”.

He scoffed, a humorless smirk rising to his lips.

“You don’t even fucking *know* me”.

“The moment you crossed that door, you became my patient. Which means I care for you”.

“Because you’re being *paid* to”.

“Yes. But also because you are a troubled young man who has gone through harsh things and who needs assistance, assistance which I am qualified to give. No one does things for only one reason. We, as human beings, are multifaceted creatures who have more than a single definition to themselves”.

“Do you rehearse that shitty speech in front of the mirror?”

“Every morning”, she smiled.

He scoffed again, going back to looking out the window. His leg bounced a few times before he spoke up.

“Well? Here’s my definition. I’m angry. I’m fucking short-tempered. I don’t have the patience to deal with people’s bullshit, and that makes them think I need some shitty therapy for some *reason* instead of minding their own business”.

Doctor Matsuo stared at him with attention, not taking any notes. He glared at her, even though he was thankful for that, before continuing.

“They want me to take the blame for a fucking problem that’s *theirs*, not mine. I want to be a fucking pro, and in order to do that, I need to come to these shitty sessions with you. Take the time to check your e-mails, catch up on whatever shitty show you’re watching or some shit like that, because I don’t plan on doing much talking, here. I’m gonna get my ass here in silence, stare at you in silence, and leave in silence”.

“I see”, she picked her pen up again, much to his annoyance, and scribbled down whatever shitty notes she was taking. “And for how long?”, she raised an eyebrow.

“Huh?”

She raised her head in order to look at him.

“For how long do you plan on coming here in silence, staring at me in silence, and leaving in silence?”, she clarified.

Katsuki glared at her.

She sighed, crossing her legs in a different position and leaning back against her armchair.

“I will be honest with you, Bakugou-kun. Until I give you official clearance, you’ll be forced by the UA board to keep attending these sessions. And, for as long as you are attending, you will not be allowed to take the test that grants you a license”, she explained, looking as sympathetic as ever. “You look like a smart boy. I’m sure you’ll agree that, given your current situation, the most profitable solution is for you to allow me to do my job and help you”.

He snarled.

“I don’t need your help”.

“You don’t have to need it”.

Silence.

He continued to glare at her.

“Fine. I’ve wanted to be a pro hero ever since I was a brat. Been training hard ever since. That’s all you gotta know about me”.

“Really?”

“Yeah, *really*”.

“So that is all that you are? A future pro hero?”

“That’s all you *have to know*”.

“Well, the thing is, Bakugou-kun”, she shifted on her seat. “I already knew that before you even stepped inside this room. I watched the sports festival; I saw the coverage of what happened at the training camp. I already know you are a very dedicated, hardworking young man, and if you didn’t want to be an excellent hero you wouldn’t submit yourself to a therapy you clearly do not want”.

He glared at her.

“But you and I both know you are more than just a young aspiring hero. And the reason why you are here, why I am here”, he sighed, setting her notebook and her pen aside and removing her reading glasses, setting all three items down on the table beside her. “Is to figure out why you are so angry”.

Katsuki growled.

“The first step to a successful anger management therapy is to *acknowledge* you are angry, and that the anger is yours, and that you are the only one who can do anything about it”, she said, so polite and sympathetic that it made Katsuki feel like an actual disrespectful child before her. She smiled and crossed her hands on her lap. “Before you can recognize you have a problem, and before you realize the problem comes from you, and not from those around you, there won’t be much I will be able to do”.

He snarled.

She stared at him for a while, almost studying him.

“Why don’t I give you an assignment for our next session?”, she suggested, picking her notebook up again. “How about… you write down on a sheet of paper everything that makes you angry, until we see each other again next week?”

Katsuki snorted, giving her a humorless smirk.

“I’m gonna hand you back a fucking book, then”.

“There’s no problem”, she smiled, unfaltering beneath his reluctance. “The more you write, the better. This way, we can directly assess what’s been causing this and try to find a way to solve it. Ok?”

He scoffed at her.

What could he probably respond? It wasn’t like he could say no.

Saying there was nothing to solve seemed like a dead end, too.

It wasn’t like he had a fucking way out of this.

It wasn’t like he could talk to anyone about this.

He felt alone.

And he hated it.

“Since this is your first session, I think it’s ok to call it a day”, she said. He was getting kind of sick of her smiling already. “I believe you have a lot to think about, and a lot of decisions to make. I’ll see you again next week?”, she asked, as if there was an actual possible way Katsuki could fucking deny without being punished for it.

“Tch”, was what he offered as a response as he stood up from the couch. He shoved his hands into his pockets and looked away as she got to her feet, leading him to the door.

“I expect you to bring the list of things that make you angry, all right?”, she repeated. Katsuki wanted to explode her office. “Also, here is my number”, she offered him a card, which he didn’t take. “In case you have a problem and need to reschedule. Should anything happen, you can just call me or send me a text, ok?”

He glared at her, then at the card, then at her again.

He took the card.

She opened the door, still smiling at him, still acting as if there was anything to smile about.

“See you, Bakugou-kun”.

He didn’t offer her a response as he walked past her and marched away.

List of things that make me angry

The fucking therapy session

Shitty Hair trying to talk to me whenever I walk by

Everyone asking me fucking questions

The looks Round Face keeps giving me

The looks Aizawa sensei keeps giving me

The looks everyone keeps giving me

The fact that no one seems to mind their own fucking business

My dad fucking calling me all the time

The fucking hearing aid that hurts my damn ear

The fucking texts people keep sending me

The fucking structure of my room

The fact that there are no fucking apples around (why the fuck didn't these fuckers buy some goddamn fucking apples?? Is that really so fucking hard??)

My fucking phone

The fucking curtains that can't stay fucking closed because even though I closed the damn window all the way through some creepy fucking breeze keeps coming in and making them part

The fucking view

The fucking bed

The fucking tie Shitty Hair shoved beneath my door (I didn't fucking ask it back)

Fucking shitty stupid Deku

Katsuki glared at the paper.

~~Fucking shitty stupid Deku~~

He woke up hours later, and taking a glimpse at his digital clock, he found it was still 10 p.m.

Well, *already* 10 p.m. He didn't think the difference really mattered.

He didn't remember falling asleep. He didn't even understand why that had happened. He only carried the weight of one soul with him now. No reason to be so tired.

He was hungry. That was one of the things he was feeling. Maybe that was why he was so weak and sleepy. He would feel better after he ate something.

He would *have* to feel better, eventually. He couldn't feel this way forever.

Kirishima and Kaminari were at the common room when he walked – or rather, marched – into the kitchen. To no one's surprise, Kirishima followed him in, like he seemed to have grown used to doing recently.

He opened the fridge and looked around. Still no fucking apples.

Was this a fucking joke?

"Hey, man".

Katsuki crouched down. There was no way there wasn't a single damn apple in that damn fridge.

"Uh… Watcha looking for?"

Katsuki squinted, reached out, opened drawers. Nothing.

He stood up and slammed the fridge door closed with way more force than necessary. The fridge rattled, threatening to topple back, but stood firm. He had probably fucked the door's magnetics up, though.

He stormed out of the kitchen, headed towards the stairs. He was better off going back to the damn bedroom – he wasn't in the mood to go all the way to the cafeteria just to grab a bite.

He could feel Kaminari's eyes on him as he passed by the couch, and he could just tell Kirishima was following him closely.

He arrived at his bedroom. Opened the door, stepped inside. Pushed it closed.

The door never slammed. Kirishima held it with one hand, not allowing it to close.

“Can I come in?”

Katsuki kept his back turned to him in silence, sitting by his studying desk and turning his laptop on. He needed to study. That was the only thing he needed to do. He needed to be on the top of his game if he wanted to get a degree from that fucking school instead of being kicked out like a damn dog.

“I’m not coming in unless you give me permission, bro”, Kirishima insisted.

That finally earned a snort from Katsuki.

“As if that ever fucking stopped you before”. *Hypocrite*.

“Can I come in?”, was all Kirishima said in response.

Katsuki sighed. Typed in his password. Opened his browser. Grabbed his notebook. Suppressed the urge to yank his hearing aid out of his ear again.

(He shouldn’t keep doing that, probably. He didn’t know the likeliness of getting a new one in case this one broke down).

“Whatever”.

The light from the hallway was cut off as his bedroom door closed, but Katsuki couldn’t really tell whether Kirishima had entered the room or left like a kicked puppy until the boy appeared beside him, sitting on the edge of his bed and giving Katsuki a look he decided to ignore.

He didn’t like that look.

There was silence for a while.

“What are you doing?”

Katsuki scoffed.

“Studying”.

“Oh”.

Silence.

“I didn’t think you would be. Studying. Today, I mean”.

He glared at his friend.

“Why wouldn’t I be studying today?”

Silence.

“Well… You know”.

Katsuki didn’t look at him. His jaw was tensed up, a vein threatening to pop at his temple.

“I *don’t*”.

“The… The, uh. The Midoriya thing”.

Silence.

“Tomorrow’s… Well, uh, it’s the last day”.

“Yeah, I fucking *know* that”.

A pause.

“I thought –“

“I don’t care”.

A pause.

“W-What?”

“I don’t care what you thought”.

“*Oh*. That”.

“Is that all?”

Kirishima stared at him.

“No. That’s not all, man”.

Katsuki turned his head to glare at him again.

“Then fucking *what*?”

Kirishima stared at him as if he had grown a second head. No, worse than that – he looked at him as if he had actually hurt him, on purpose.

“*Bakugou*”.

“*What*?”

The boy scoffed in disbelief, looking almost offended.

“*Seriously*, man? You’re still not gonna *talk* to me about this?”

“About *what*? I’m not a fucking mind reader”.

“About what *happened*, man. About finding out Midoriya was dying, about going to the sewers without telling me anything about it, about facing off a bunch of villains”, he shook his head slightly. “About how you faced trial, about how you were almost expelled, about literally *every single thing* that happened these past few days”.

Katsuki looked away and stared at his computer screen.

Kirishima waited for a response.

“I mean, seriously?”, he scoffed at the silence, hurt. “I thought you were my friend”.

Katsuki stayed silent.

“But friends don’t do this to each other. Friends tell each other when they have problems. Friends tell each other when they need help –“

“I didn’t fucking *need* help –“

“And friends *tell each* other when they lose their damn *hearing*”.

Katsuki glared at Kirishima. He was being fucking annoying, and Katsuki wasn’t exactly having the best of days. All he wanted was to be left alone. He was angry, he was pressured, he was guilty, he was hungry and couldn’t have the fucking food he wanted. He was about to crack, because everyone was pulling at him from different directions, and he knew he would end up losing it if he didn’t catch a break.

That’s what he needed. Just a break, to get his shit together, to prove to all those bastards that he didn’t need any damn therapy. He could do this. He didn’t fucking need anyone; he could do this.

Kirishima stood his ground.

“What? You didn’t think I’d find out?”, he asked, eyes moist in the darkness of the room. “You didn’t think I’d ask Recovery Girl about it, and Aizawa sensei about it, and anyone who was willing to give me some answers when *you* didn’t?”

Katsuki stared at him.

“You’re one nosy son of a bitch”, he scoffed.

“Oh my god, man, *seriously*? Are you *seriously* gonna pull that off?”

“I don’t know what you fucking want me to say, Kirishima, and this isn’t the best fucking time for you to push me”.

Kirishima stared at him, looking like he was about to cry.

“I just want to know why you didn’t tell me about any of this. Why you’re shutting me out, and everyone who cares about you with me. I want you to tell me how you’re feeling, and what I can do to *help* you, man”.

For some reason, that last statement made Katsuki even more furious. He felt like a teapot.

“I didn’t fucking tell you about it because I didn’t want your stupid ass to be expelled, too, you fucker. Can you fucking *leave* now?”

Kirishima stared at him. Katsuki glared back.

“So you knew you could be expelled and you went anyway?”

“You tell me. Didn’t your fucking teachers snitch to you about what happened?”

Kirishima scoffed wetly, shaking his head slightly before pausing, as if he had just experienced an epiphany.

“Is this about the F-word?”

Katsuki could feel the blood draining from his face and his hands instinctively curled up into fists. He looked away, teeth and gums exposed to the chilly air of the room as he snarled.

Kirishima had promised he wouldn’t talk about that shit inside his bedroom.

“Because you didn’t tell –“

“*Don’t*”.

Silence.

“I *don’t* want to fucking talk about this”.

“Why?”

“Because I don’t fucking *want* to”.

Kirishima stared at him.

“Ok, but I think –“

“If you insist, I’m gonna kick you the fuck out of here”, he slammed one fist on his desk, making his pen fall to the floor.

Silence. Kirishima bent over to pick the pen up and settled it back down on the top of Katsuki’s open notebook.

“Ok”.

Katsuki went back to his studies. Kirishima stayed where he was.

It was hard to concentrate, knowing his best friend was right there. Knowing he was thinking about… *that*. He had to read the same sentence three times over before he realized he was getting no study done with Kirishima there, lurking in the dark beside him like a fucking nosy gargoyle.

There was a lot. In his brain, in his heart. In his soul.

He could just feel himself about to explode, like a volcano, like a natural disaster. All it would take was a little push in the wrong direction.

“I think you should go there”, Kirishima ended up breaking the silence a moment after Katsuki decided he was better off kicking him out of his room before his friend unavoidably led him towards an angry outburst.

He paused.

“What?”

“At the medical bay. Everyone’s there”.

Katsuki snorted, trying to take a deep breath and not lose it.

“That’s a good fucking reason why I *shouldn’t* go there”.

Kirishima sighed.

“I don’t know what to tell you. I still think you should go”.

“If you don’t fucking know what to tell me, stay fucking silent”.

Kirishima complied for short moments, before breaking the silence again.

“I honestly… I honestly don’t know what to do with you, Bakugou”.

Katsuki glared at Kirishima.

He looked sad. In a defeatist way. In a disturbing way. Like he was completely helpless.

Katsuki didn’t like it. It made him angry.

It made him guilty.

He wasn’t used to feeling guilt. That was a weak, pathetic feeling that he had never experienced until shitty Deku imposed himself onto his life.

He was probably having a laugh now, wherever he was. Seeing Katsuki fail, seeing Katsuki be weak. Seeing Katsuki feel guilt for…

It… It made him angry.

It was easier to be angry. *Angry* was a feeling he was used to. It was familiar. It was like homecoming. It was almost comforting, at this point.

It was something he could deal with, unlike everything else that was happening.

“I mean… You’re different, man”, Kirishima continued.

Katsuki’s hands tightened into fists again.

“The fuck do you mean?”

Kirishima opened and closed his mouth, as if he didn’t know what to say.

“You look… sad?”

Silence.

Katsuki didn’t know how to handle sad. All Katsuki knew how to handle was *angry*.

“And I’d never seen you like this. You’re *always* angry”.

He scoffed. The fuck was Kirishima getting at?

“And I can deal with angry you, and with bitchy you, and with rude you, but… I don’t know how I can help you like this. I don’t know what happened exactly, no one seems to know all the details, and you don’t want to tell me, and I know better than to push it, so I don’t know how to make you feel better”.

Kirishima gave him a helpless look.

Katsuki fumed. For some reason, Kirishima’s statement annoyed him, in a way that set off all different types of red alert inside his brain. In a way that sent him back to his comfort zone.

“Oh, you want me to be *fucking angry*? Is that what you prefer, Shitty Hair?”, he growled, standing up from his chair.

Kirishima sighed, raising one calming hands towards him. It was too late – the anger was taking Katsuki over, like magma, like hellfire, like pain.

Feral animals attack you when they’re wounded, even if you’re only trying to help.

Katsuki was feeling pretty much feral.

“*No*. I’d prefer you to tell me what’s going on with you, and how I can help”, Kirishima attempted.

“*Nothing’s* going on with me. I’m perfectly fucking normal, and I don’t need your brainless *shitty* head to keep trying to dig dirt on me and to tell me what to fucking do”, he knocked his computer chair down with one hand in his anger, taking a step towards Kirishima. The boy

stood up from the bed, now raising two hands towards his friend. Katsuki's fists were already fuming.

"Bakugou –"

"You think you know *shit*? You think I'm fucking *sad*?", Katsuki snarled, exposing his teeth. Fire flowed in his veins. "I ain't fucking *sad*, Kirishima, I'm fucking *furious*", he growled. "I'm fucking deaf, I have to fucking go to therapy in order to stay here, I have to fucking deal with people accusing me of shit I didn't mean to do, I have to fucking deal with the fucking fact that I almost *killed* the fucking villain and shitty fucking *stupid* Deku with him. And now that motherfucker's gone and I don't know if he'll survive and he fucking *left* and now I have to deal with *all* of my goddamn anger again. He fucking left, Kirishima, in front of my fucking eyes, and there was nothing I could do, and you know what's the last thing the asshole did? You know what was the last goddamn thing he tried to fucking do? He tried to fucking pass his fucking quirk to me, he tried to fucking impose it on me even though I didn't ask him to, and the only reason he didn't do that was because he fucking became intangible before he could and he just vanished before I could even – before I could even tell him any fucking thing –"

It was getting hard to breathe. His chest was feeling tight, not enough air making it into his fucking lungs. The anger was choking him.

Kirishima touched his shoulder, clearly in an attempt to comfort him, but Katsuki batted his hand away aggressively before he could do anything.

He had grown spoiled, having Deku share his anger. He had spent a month feeling only half of his rage, and now everything was back, everything was flooding him, everything was overwhelming him, every single drop of his fury, and he couldn't breathe, not with that fire in his heart, not with that smoke in his lungs.

This was just too much.

"And I bet that motherfucker's having a laugh right now, hah?", he continued, panting, gasping, *angry*, trying his best to stay strong and stay sane despite the smothering feeling in his lungs. "I bet he's having a fucking laugh from the fucking beyond, because he can see me, and I can't see him, and that's just fucking hilarious, right? He fucking carried half my anger for a whole damn month, and now he's gone, and I have to deal with all of these shitty feelings on my own, there's no one to balance it out, and what do you think, hah, me going to *therapy*? To goddamn fucking *anger management* therapy, because you were too much of an asshole not to get your fucking ass fucking captured like an *idiot*!"

Kirishima frowned, confused.

"Bakugou, what are you talking about–"

"You had to let that asshole get you so easily, didn't you, *damn Deku*?", Katsuki choked out past his panting, teeth gritted, hands fisted, shoulders slumped and heaving with each heavy, angry breath he took. His voice was guttural, his throat was raw. "You fucking *had* to get

yourself captured like a helpless fucking maiden and leave all the hard work to me fucking again, like you've been doing all your damn life!"

"Hey, man, calm –"

"What do you want me to fucking tell you? *Hah*? That I'm fucking sorry? Is that what your shitty nerd ass wants to *fucking* hear?", he shouted, pushing Kirishima away with more force than necessary and knocking down his lamp.

I'll apologize when I'm dead.

Or when I am

"*Fine*", Katsuki half-growled, half-screamed, feeling like he was about to crack, like he was about to crack open like an egg and spew his insides on the floor. Magma, lava, fire. He needed to let it all out before it tore him apart from the inside. "I'm fucking *sorry*. I'm fucking sorry for all those times I was an asshole to you, I'm sorry for putting you down, I'm sorry for letting go of you. I'm sorry for *fucking letting go of you*, even though I promised I wouldn't. Is that what you wanted to *fucking* hear?"

Kirishima stared at him in stunned silence.

"So where the fuck are you, hah?", Katsuki asked to the ceiling. "Where the *fuck* are you, you fucking, shitty, *smug* bastard?"

He grabbed one of the pillows that formed the pillow fort and threw them with all his might against the wall, his fuming hands leaving scorch marks on the white fabric. Then he grabbed another, and another, and another, until all the pillows had flopped down on the top of his bed after colliding with the harsh surface.

"Where the fuck – you stupid piece of fucking shit – you fucking goddamn fucking bastard – where the fuck did you fucking – I *fucking* –"

He was interrupted by Kirishima grabbing him and pulling him into a tight hug, enveloping him with a strong hold and securely locking Katsuki's arms beside his body in a way he couldn't move.

Only then did Katsuki realize he was sobbing.

Oh. That's why he couldn't breathe.

"Let *go* of me, Kirishima", he said, a half-growl, half-sob – a sound that ended up like a guttural shout. "Let fucking *go* of me", he tried to push Kirishima away, his voice muffled by the boy's shoulder.

"No", Kirishima said simply, Katsuki's order only resulting on a tighter hug. He was being squeezed and there was too much physical contact, but he couldn't break free, and he didn't really have the strength – or the will – to try.

Katsuki buried his face on Kirishima's neck, gasping, his arms hanging limply beside his body. Kirishima held him in silence, never loosening his grasp, as if he was afraid that Katsuki would fall apart and come undone if he did.

"He's gone, man", Kirishima said against his skin as his shoulders rattled. "I'm sorry, but he's gone. He can't hear you anymore".

Katsuki didn't have a response to that, so he just allowed himself to be held by Kirishima.

He left early, as usual.

He strolled by himself, took in the cool breeze against his face, made his way to the classroom. Stepped in, took his seat, opened his notebook, and he would have ignored the attempts to talk to him, had there been any.

Kirishima kept sending him worried looks, but he knew better than to talk to Katsuki about *that* subject in public.

Icy Hot had a cast around his right arm. Katsuki wondered if he had broken it from the effort of building the ice wall to protect himself and his friends from his howitzer.

He didn't ask him about it.

He had class, walked out, had lunch, went back to class.

Went to his room.

Lied on his bed.

Tried not to think about the fact that there were no days left.

This was the last one.

The pillows were still there, flopped on the bed, on the same spot Katsuki had left them after throwing them against the wall.

For some reason, the sight made him angry.

List of things that make me angry

Instead of setting the pen down, he threw it across the room. He sat down, ran a hand through his spiky hair.

He took his clothes off, entered the bathroom, took a shower. Stayed in for longer than he should have.

Stepped out, cleared the misty mirror on his wall. Stared at his reflection.

Realized he had forgotten to take his clothes with him.

“I forgot to take my fucking clothes in again, so you’d better look the fuck –“, he started to say out of habit as he stepped out, before realizing there was no one there. “ – … Away”.

He stood there. His room was empty.

Oh.

He stood there for a while.

He put some clothes on and grabbed his phone.

167 new texts

13 missed calls

6 new voicemails

He put the device down, grabbing his notebook and sitting on his bed. He had to study. He couldn’t fall behind.

But I don’t get it, Kacchan, if that’s how you calculate it, then how –

Will you shut the fuck up and let me explain it or what?

He scoffed. Quirk theory. He had to focus on quirk theory. There was an exam coming up soon.

I thought quirks were everything to you

The hell does that mean?

Well, you stopped being my friend after you found out I was quirkless

He closed the notebook and threw it across the room. *Fine.*

He grabbed a book Aizawa sensei had told them to read. It wasn't his priority, but he'd better get it done with now that he couldn't concentrate on more urgent matters.

The font was too small. He grabbed his reading glasses from the studying desk's drawer.

Wow, Kacchan, those glasses really suit you!

Eeh?

He closed his eyes. Took a deep breath.

I'm getting really worried right now, Katchuki

"Fuck it", he threw the book – whose pages were already started to get all shriveled up from the heat emanating from his hands – against the wall as well, standing up from his bed. "*Fuck* it. Fuck it, fuck you, just – *fuck*".

He grabbed another book that was sitting in his studying desk and launched it against the wall with a loud thump.

He breathed in, breathed out. Hated the world, hated Deku, hated the villain, hated himself.

Then he put his shoes on and walked out.

There was no one in the med bay when he arrived, except for All Might and Recovery Girl.

They gave him weird looks when he arrived, as if they hadn't expected him to show up.

Katsuki stopped in front of them, silent. In his eyes, the fury of a thousand suns.

"Bakugou *shonen* –"

"I want to see him".

All Might and Recovery Girl exchanged looks.

"I understand –"

"I *will* see him".

“No, you won’t”, Recovery Girl gave him a serious look, shifting on her feet ever so subtly as if to position herself between Deku’s door and Katsuki. “I understand the situation, but Midoriya’s body is still too fragile. He can’t be in contact with anyone right now, because his immune system –“

“What fucking *difference* does it make? He’s going to die anyway”, Katsuki interrupted. “I just want to tell some truths to the fucker before he actually kicks the bucket”, he added, trying to walk past the small woman. She stopped Katsuki by placing her cane in front of him, at the same time All Might held a hand to his shoulder.

Recovery Girl gave him a disapproving look, whereas All Might stared at him with confusion. However, neither of those looks lingered on their faces for too long – they were both replaced by something else, something that seemed like a mixture of hope and guilt, sorrow and happiness.

Katsuki hated it.

“The thing is, *shonen*…”, All Might was the one who spoke up first, his hand on Katsuki’s shoulder firm. “There… Is a chance Young Midoriya will make it through the night”.

Katsuki stared at him, face blank of emotion.

“And through *other* nights”, Recovery Girl added, sounding as stern as ever. She lowered her cane, but stayed in front of Katsuki in case he tried to walk past her again. “Which is why we can’t have you barging in with all your germs and bacteria and have him die from infection after all the trouble we’ve all gone through”.

Katsuki stared at her, and the information he was being told was so baffling, so out-of-this-world that he didn’t even have the heart to complain about being called a filthy diseased kid. So Deku wouldn’t *die*? There was a chance he would actually *make it*?

He stared at All Might again.

“But how the hell is that possible?”, he asked, hating, absolutely *hating* the way his voice sounded hopeful. “And why the *hell* didn’t you tell anyone about it?!”, he added angrily, just so that he didn’t lose habit.

“Because it’s not done yet”, Recovery Girl intervened again, making Katsuki snap his head towards her. “And we didn’t want to give anyone false hope. But since you look like you’re about to force yourself into his room, and since it is almost done… I don’t see why you shouldn’t know”.

Katsuki stared at All Might again. He was oddly quiet.

Too quiet.

Katsuki squinted.

“I’ll give you boys some alone time to talk”, Recovery Girl announced with a sigh, retrieving her cane and walking away. All Might waited until she was out of ear range in order to speak

up.

“Bakugou shonen –“

“Since *what* is almost done?”

All Might blinked at him.

“I’m sorry?”

“She said there was no problem telling me, since it’s almost done. *What* is almost done?”

All Might sighed.

“The villain woke up”.

Katsuki’s hands tightened into fists.

“It took a lot of Recovery Girl’s energy to make him regain consciousness and it was a tricky job, because of the severe head injury he suffered from your blow, but that was a vital factor for the plan we had in mind. After all, Young Shinsou’s quirk only works on people who willingly reply to his questions”.

Katsuki’s eye twitched a little.

“You sent that purple-haired bastard to *brainwash* the damn villain?!”

“I doubt the villain would have agreed to return Young Midoriya’s soul to his body out of the kindness of his heart, as you’ll have to agree, *shonen*”, All Might told him, crossing his arms above his chest. “Unfortunately, in a situation like this, an innocent student’s life outranks the freedom of a criminal and a villain. Just as Young Shinsou will, in the future, use his quirk to brainwash villains into surrendering and complying with the police, he is now using it to compel the villain to return Young Midoriya’s soul to where it belongs”.

Katsuki stared at All Might, not knowing what to think or how to feel about the information he was being told.

Deku would live.

“The process, of course, is tricky”, All Might continued. “The villain is weak and still recovering, and Young Shinsou is still a student. There are plenty of things that could go wrong, and the last thing the school needs on this moment is to have another student be injured at the hands of this criminal. Eraser is in the room with them, overseeing the operation. As soon as the villain is coherent enough, we will attempt to make him return Young Midoriya’s soul”.

Katsuki stared at him.

Deku would live.

“We also found something out about his quirk”, All Might went on, completely oblivious to the fact that Katsuki couldn’t care less about the douchebag’s quirk, or about anything other than the fact that Deku would live.

Deku would live, which meant Katsuki wouldn’t have to feel so guilty anymore.

Deku would live, which meant that being separated from him wouldn’t have to last for much longer.

Deku would live, which meant he had wasted the past two days freaking out over nothing like an idiot.

Deku would live, which meant he wasn’t gone forever.

Deku would live.

Deku would fucking live.

“The villain can also take control of the people whose souls he steals”, All Might continued. “He managed to capture the soul of a very close friend of mine, who works with the police and was pursuing him on Young Midoriya’s behalf. We didn’t notice because, unlike it happened to you, my friend’s soul ended up in the villain’s hands. He was controlling him and giving us, as well as the police, false information for almost a month, which resulted on us chasing our own tails and almost losing a life in the process”.

Katsuki stared up at All Might, a serious look taking over his face. That made a lot of sense – why UA, a renowned school of heroes, had spent an entire month without being able to capture a simple villain. Why one of their students almost died, and got worse and worse with each passing day, and they did nothing.

Why they shut out Deku’s mom and Deku’s friends and hid important information from everyone who cared about him. Why they acted like fucking *idiots*.

“So that bullshit is over, now?”

“Young Shinsou will use his quirk to make the villain return my friend’s soul in the process, as well”.

“No. I mean the lying bullshit. The hiding-important-information bullshit. This thing you all had going on before”, Katsuki clarified, staring at All Might with evident anger and resentment.

All Might had the decency to look embarrassed.

“Yes. That will not happen anymore”.

Katsuki glared at him.

Then nodded.

“And you’ve told his mom?”

All Might lowered his head, but didn’t break eye-contact with Katsuki.

“Not yet. We will wait until it is done”.

“Why in the *goddamn* –“, Katsuki started, his voice raising, but All Might interrupted him before he could lose it too hard.

“Though we have more hope than we did in the entirety of the past month, Young Midoriya is not out of the woods yet”, All Might told him in a lower tone, grabbing Katsuki’s shoulder and leaning in closer to him. “It would be cruel to give his mother hope, only to have it snatched away from her. Especially after everything she’s been going through”.

Katsuki glared at All Might, but decided it would be better not to argue. He wasn’t wrong – it would be a fucking nightmare to tell Inko Midoriya that her son would live, only for Purple Hair to fuck up and end up getting Deku killed. Katsuki couldn’t *imagine* what her reaction would be.

He didn’t want to. He didn’t even want to read her damn texts or listen to her damn voicemails.

He wished she hated him harder than she did.

“I appreciate your concern for Mrs. Midoriya”, All Might added after a few moments of awkward silence.

“I’m not concerned –“, Katsuki tried to protest out of habit.

“I’m sure she does, too”.

Katsuki stared at him.

“She visited you, at the infirmary. After you were taken in”.

Katsuki’s jaw grew tight from anger.

“I don’t remember it”.

“That’s ok, *shonen*”.

“Whatever”, he muttered angrily through gritted teeth, looking away.

“She is not angry at you. And I believe you should pay her a visit”.

Katsuki glared at All Might.

“And why the fuck would I do that?”

All Might sighed, displeased with Katsuki’s foul language, but knowing better than attempting to correct it at such a tense situation.

“Because I believe you care for her, as well”.

“I don’t give a *shit* about her”.

All Might suppressed a smile.

“If you didn’t care for her, *shonen*, you wouldn’t worry about her not knowing information about Young Midoriya”.

Katsuki scoffed at him.

“I worry about her not knowing shit because I’m the one she comes to whenever you bastards hide stuff from her”.

All Might gave him a disbelieving look.

“What? That’s all there is to it!”, he protested angrily.

“Either way”, the hero sighed. “You should speak to her. She is back there at the waiting room”.

“I thought you said she didn’t know about what’s going on”.

“She doesn’t”, All Might nodded. “She just wanted to be with her son in…”, he took a deep breath, as if he couldn’t quite bring himself to say the words. “In his final… moments”.

Katsuki glared at him.

“You should have a serious talk with Deku once he wakes up”.

All Might’s grief turned into curiosity.

“Why is that?”

Katsuki glared at him. He looked around them, at the corridor, to check if there was anyone around, before leaning in closer to All Might.

Now that his hearing was impaired, he was never sure whether he was speaking too loudly or not. More often than not, it didn’t matter – he knew he was a loud person, always screaming and shouting at people, so raising his voice wasn’t really a big deal to him. However, when it came to talking about All Might’s secret – about Deku’s quirk – he needed to be more careful.

Which reminded him there was something he should do once he was done talking to the symbol of peace.

“He tried to pass me One For All before he vanished”, he told All Might in a low voice.

All Might stared at him with a blank face.

“He grabbed his hair and tried to shove it in my mouth. The only reason he couldn’t was because he became intangible at that moment”.

All Might continued to stare at him. Katsuki couldn’t be sure, but he thought he could see tears forming in the older man’s eyes.

“Well…”, he squeezed Katsuki’s shoulder after a few moments of silence, voice firm but sounding thick with emotion. “I, for one, can guarantee that there is no one Young Midoriya would deem worthier of his power than you”.

Katsuki stared at All Might.

He did not like that statement. It bothered him.

I think he wanted you to be the hero he thought he would never get to be, you know?

He shrugged All Might’s hand away from his shoulder. Enough touching for that day.

“I was the only one he could touch and who he could actually pass the quirk on to”, Katsuki tried to justify, though his argument sounded weak to his own ears.

All Might offered him a sad smile in response.

“You have grown a lot this past month, Young Bakugou”, he said, something akin to pride in his voice. “But you still have a long path ahead of you”.

Katsuki glared at All Might.

“If you’ll excuse me for a moment, I need the bathroom”, All Might announced, patting Katsuki’s back. “Do you plan on staying here until Young Shinsou is done?”

Katsuki scoffed, shoving his hands into his pockets and leaning his back on the wall behind him.

As if he would have the spirit to just leave and go back to his room while Deku’s life was at stake.

“Yeah”.

“I figured”, All Might nodded. “I will be back in no time to keep you company. But – *shonen*”, he added, stopping himself before he could start walking off. Katsuki squinted at him. “Recovery Girl was serious about Young Midoriya’s immune system. Getting inside his room without proper clothing and equipment would endanger his life greatly”.

Katsuki glared at him before looking away and nodding briefly. The fucker actually thought he was about to break into Deku’s room as soon as he was left unsupervised, huh?

(He probably would, if his ass wasn’t already on the line and if it didn’t compromise Deku’s health).

“Yeah, I know”.

“Good. I’ll be right back”.

“Whatever”.

All Might gave him a final nod before walking away and disappearing into a corner.

Katsuki sighed, finding himself alone in the med bay’s hall. Waiting for something that he didn’t even dream could be happening barely half an hour ago.

Waiting for something he wasn’t sure would actually happen.

He had come here to say… Well. He wasn’t sure exactly what. His plan was to make his peace with Deku (even though he didn’t quite think that would actually happen) and possibly to say goodbye to the nerd or something. If Katsuki was being honest, he didn’t know what he was going to do when he made his way there.

He just knew he couldn’t stay away any longer.

And now, to find out there was a chance Deku would live, a chance Deku wouldn’t actually die despite Katsuki’s promises and reassuring that he would be fine…

He didn’t know how to feel about that. He did know that it eased his anger down, if only a little bit.

He fished his phone out of his pocket and ignored all of Kirishima’s 62 texts (which he hadn’t read for the past four days) and sending him a new one.

From: Bakubro

So, I know we’ve already talked about this and I know that, if you know what’s good for your dumb ass, you’re not gonna tell anyone about anything that happened yesterday

From: Bakubro

And I mean ANYTHING.

From: Shitty Hair

Dude. You know you can trust me

From: Shitty Hair

I’m not telling anyone anything

From: Shitty Hair

You can chill, ok?

From: Bakubro

Good

From: Shitty Hair

Though

From: Shitty Hair

Can I ask you about one thing?

From: Shitty Hair

It’s ok if you say no

From: Bakubro

Then no

From: Shitty Hair

:c

From: Bakubro

Just fucking say it already

From: Shitty Hair

Ok so

From: Shitty Hair

You know, you said something

From: Shitty Hair

You said Midoriya tried to pass you his quirk

From: Shitty Hair

Before he, you know

From: Shitty Hair

But I mean, how? Is that even possible?

Bakugou's lips formed a thin, stern line. This was precisely the subject he had been meaning to talk to Kirishima to, and the reason why he wanted to make sure the boy didn't run his mouth to anyone.

From: Bakubro

That's personal

From: Shitty Hair

?

From: Bakubro

Look, that's just a shitty game I used to play with Deku when we were kids

From: Bakubro

We played pretend that we could pass our quirks to each other

From: Bakubro

And we made a promise that if one of us was dying as heroes, we'd give our quirk to the other one

From: Bakubro

It's just a stupid kid's game, I didn't even remember about it until he tried to do it for real

From: Bakubro

And it pissed me the fuck off

Katsuki kept his eyes fixed on the screen, waiting for Kirishima's response. He could only hope the boy bought the lie and didn't ask any further questions about that sensitive subject.

Katsuki should have never told Kirishima about that, but he had been vulnerable and angry and Kirishima was the only person in the world he trusted with his life. It had been a mistake, but not a deadly one – thankfully for him, Kirishima wasn't exactly the brightest of their class, and he knew better than to insist on matters that Katsuki flagged as personal. Hell, he would probably love that made-up tender childhood story and buy it like a dumbass.

From: Shitty Hair

Bro

From: Shitty Hair

That's

From: Shitty Hair

I mean I don't even know what to say

From: Shitty Hair

That's so sweet

From: Shitty Hair

But in a manly way

From: Shitty Hair

I mean… wow

From: Shitty Hair

How are you? Do you want me to come over?

From: Bakubro

No

From: Shitty Hair

But I'm already at your door :c

From: Shitty Hair

I've been knocking for a while but I just assumed you didn't have your hearing aid on

From: Shitty Hair

So maybe… open up?

From: Bakubro

Too bad

From: Shitty Hair

Bakugouuuuuuu

From: Shitty Hair

Cmon :c

From: Shitty Hair

You shouldn’t be alone rn :c

From: Bakubro

I’ll be fine

From: Bakubro

Also I’m busy

From: Shitty Hair

Hey

From: Shitty Hair

Wait a minute

From: Shitty Hair

You’re not in your bedroom

From: Shitty Hair

Are you?

From: Shitty Hair

Where are you man?

From: Shitty Hair

You’re not getting in trouble again, are you?

From: Shitty Hair

Oh my god Bakugou what are you doing

From: Shitty Hair

Where are you

From: Shitty Hair

I swear to god you’re giving me gray hairs

From: Shitty Hair

And gray doesn’t go with red

From: Shitty Hair

Dude, seriously. You're on thin ice. You shouldn't be getting yourself in trouble

From: Shitty Hair

Where are you? I'm going to pick you up

From: Shitty Hair

Tell me where you are

From: Shitty Hair

I'm worried

From: Shitty Hair

Hey

From: Shitty Hair

Hey

From: Shitty Hair

Hey

From: Shitty Hair

Hey

Katsuki turned his phone off and placed it back into his pocket before Kirishima could decide to call him, and without checking any of his other messages.

The first thought that crossed his mind as soon as a tired, worn out Shinsou walked past him on the hall without sparing him a single glance was that it was stupid of UA to have placed a dangerous, potentially murderous villain on the same damn hall as Deku's weakened body.

The second thought that crossed his mind was that Aizawa sensei looked serious, but that told him nothing, since the man was always serious.

The third thought that crossed his mind was that, if UA had placed such a dangerous villain on the same damn hall as Deku, that could only mean the villain was too fucked up to do anything threatening.

Shinsou walked straight past them and disappeared on the hall without saying a word. Aizawa sensei stopped to talk to All Might, and Katsuki just stood there, ready to hear whatever he was about to say.

He hated the way his heart was thumping anxiously in his chest in anticipation for what he was about to hear.

"So?", All Might broke the silence, clearly as anxious as Katsuki but showing it much more explicitly. Aizawa sensei sighed.

"Shinsou assures me he returned the souls. Recovery Girl is getting geared up to go check for herself", he said in a deadpan. He wasn't even looking at Katsuki, as if he wasn't there in the first place.

"And how long will that take?", All Might inquired.

"Standard time", was Aizawa sensei's dry response. "Shinsou left because the session tired him out and he has training early in the morning, but he'll come back should any problem arise".

"What use will it be?", Katsuki scoffed.

Both teachers turned to look at him, Aizawa sensei acknowledging his presence for the first time.

"It's almost midnight. There's no way we'll be able to bring him back here and try that shit all over again if the old lady finds that Deku's soul is still with the villain", he clarified.

All Might sighed, running a tired hand across his face.

"Bakugou *shonen* –"

"Don't try to exempt yourself from your responsibility in this", Aizawa sensei told him sternly, not in a hateful tone, but in a scolding one. "If you hadn't almost killed the villain, we would have had more time to try and return Midoriya's soul".

Katsuki looked away, glaring at the wall. He desperately wanted to offer a bratty response, but he knew better than to do that. He was on the spotlight, and he would be for a while – he couldn't risk talking back to a teacher and giving UA even more reasons to expel him, especially when the teacher in question was Aizawa sensei, who had a reputation for kicking students out.

Also, he wasn't exactly in the right here. Aizawa sensei wasn't telling him any lies.

“I can’t congratulate you for what you did, Bakugou”, Aizawa continued, sounding as stern and tired as ever. All Might’s eyes kept darting between the two of them, unsure if he should allow Aizawa to have that talk with Katsuki on that moment or if she should intervene. “Your actions were reckless and impulsive. Which is a surprise, really, since you always seem to think before you act, no matter how short-tempered you are”.

Katsuki half-stared, half-glared at his teacher, silent. He couldn’t risk talking back. Aizawa was giving him an impassive, almost analyzing look. *That wasn’t wrong, either*.

“The only exception for that seems to be Midoriya, of course, if that childish fight you two had a while ago serves to prove anything”, he added.

Katsuki could feel the blood draining from his face.

“Which is why I can’t congratulate you, but I can’t say you were in the wrong, either”, Aizawa continued. “If I believed you *were* wrong, I wouldn’t have spoken up for you on the counsel”.

Katsuki frowned.

“You did?”

Aizawa sensei sighed, sounding like he just wanted to get back to his sleeping bag and go to his room.

“You’re a good student, Bakugou. More than that, you have potential. As long as you keep working on your anger issues, I believe we can shape you into becoming a fine hero, one day”.

Katsuki stared at him. He didn’t know what to say to that.

He felt like he should feel prouder for being told that.

“I will go inform the Principal of our progress”, Aizawa turned to tell All Might, as if he hadn’t just said something incredibly meaningful for Katsuki. “Recovery Girl should go in any minute now. Call me if anything happens”.

“Thank you, Shouta”, All Might nodded at him, and just like that, Aizawa sensei left.

Katsuki stared at All Might. All Might stared back at him.

An awkward silence fell upon them.

“That was… Oddly nice”, All Might commented.

Katsuki’s response consisted of huffing through his nose and looking away.

“And I agree with him. Though your actions were reckless… We can hardly blame you”.

Katsuki stared at him.

“We failed you as a school. We should have known better”.

Katsuki huffed again, shoving his hands into his pockets and leaning against the wall.

“Yeah”.

“And even though you did almost kill a villain, which isn’t a heroic action…”, All Might lowered his head. “You are still a student in training. It’s expectable that you still lose control of your quirk sometimes”.

“I didn’t”.

A pause.

“I knew exactly what I was doing”.

He raised his eyes to look at All Might and see his reaction. All Might stared at him.

He felt exposed and vulnerable. But this was his childhood idol, the man whose fall Katsuki was responsible for. All Might had been honest with him and entrusted his secret to him; it was only fair Katsuki was honest with him, too.

“That fucker grabbed Deku and dragged him across the floor like a dog”, he continued, teeth gritted, staring deep into All Might’s eyes. “He was screaming in pain. And then he fucking *teased* us when I finally got to him. After Deku disappeared, he simply strolled away, like he had fucking gone shopping or some shit”.

All Might’s lips formed a thin line.

“I had to do something. I couldn’t let him walk away”.

There was silence for a while.

“Not after that”.

“I understand”.

“You *don’t*”, he scoffed.

“I *do*”.

A pause.

“I know what it’s like, to feel that sort of anger when a villain hurts someone you love. When a villain… takes someone away from you. I have been in your shoes, *shonen*”.

Katsuki studied his mentor’s face.

“And, like you, I was reckless. I allowed my feelings to take the best of me, and I sought revenge, and now…”, he looked away, pensive. “Well. I am no longer the symbol of peace”.

Katsuki felt a twinge of guilt in his heart at the words. All Might must have noticed, because in no time there was a comforting hand on his shoulder.

“I meant it when I told you you were not to blame for my demise, Young Bakugou”, he said. “What happened, happened because of my own actions, my own recklessness. The choices I made led me towards this path”.

Katsuki watched him.

“We should just be thankful that your recklessness did not have such deadly results”.

Katsuki scoffed.

“We don’t know that yet”.

“I believe we are about to find out”, All Might nodded at the end of the hall.

Recovery Girl was arriving, fully dressed in a special medical clothing that prevented her from contaminating Deku’s fragile immune system. She did not have her ever constant cane with her, but Katsuki supposed that was a matter of necessity.

She nodded at them as she walked past them, stopping only to give All Might an unreadable look.

“Take the boy with you to the waiting room”, she instructed. “Wait for me there. I will be with you in a moment”.

“Chiyo”, was All Might said in response, a silent pleading in his tone.

“I need space to work, Toshinori”, she responded sternly. “You two won’t be of any help to me here”.

All Might stared at her for a moment before nodding respectfully. With a sigh, he tapped Katsuki’s shoulder and gently pushed him to follow him.

Katsuki, for once, obeyed without reluctance, without complaining, without a snarky response.

He was well aware that there were higher things at stake than his pride.

The waiting room was filled to the brim with people.

Katsuki immediately wanted to leave, but there was nowhere he could go.

The entirety of Class 1-A was there. Even that weird French Wannabe was there, holding a tray of cheese, for some reason. Grape Boy and Arms Guy were there too. Bird Brain and Frog Girl were sitting together at the last row of chairs, Invisible Girl and Tail Guy were whispering to each other in a corner, there were even people from Class 1-B.

Katsuki saw Purple Hair was there, too. "*Too tired and needing to rest*", his ass.

The first row of chairs, of course, consisted of Round Face, Four Eyes, Icy Hot, and, surprisingly, Kirishima. He was the only one who stood up when Katsuki arrived, giving the boy a half-worried, half-proud look.

Katsuki stared at every face in the room, and every face seemed to stare back at him. He did not like this, not one bit.

All Might leaned in closer to him, mindful to speak into his good ear.

"There is another room in here. It's reserved for family and special ones", he said.

Katsuki stared at Uraraka, seeing the fear in her eyes, and at Iida, seeing the tiredness and the concern in them. Even Icy Hot's eyes were different, something unreadable shining in them.

They belonged in the room for special ones. Not Katsuki.

Because, at the end of the day, Katsuki was just the bully who happened to get stuck with Deku's soul. That didn't make him special. That didn't make him worthy of sharing the same room with All Might, or with Inko, or with Deku's actual friends.

(And it wasn't like he was ready to face Deku's mom just yet).

And the worst part was that he *knew* that it should piss him off, not being worthy of something. But he wasn't. He knew he wasn't.

Not of this.

Not after he almost killed Deku, for real, *permanently*.

"I'll stay here", he told All Might without looking at him.

"Bakugou *shonen*…", All Might tried to argue.

"Don't", Katsuki said simply, walking away from All Might and heading towards Kirishima.

He didn't belong in that special ones room. It didn't feel right, not when all these people were out there waiting for the same news as him. Not when Uraraka and Iida were there, looking like they hadn't slept, looking like their worlds were ending.

All Might didn't insist on the matter, walking towards the room and leaving Katsuki be. He entered it in silence, closed the door behind him, and that was it.

Katsuki was alone in a room full of people.

“Hey, man”, Kirishima greeted him, leading him towards an empty row of seats that was as far away from everyone else in the room as it could be. He was speaking in a low tone, which frankly was making it hard for Katsuki to understand what he was saying, but at least he took the seat beside his good ear, which helped things a bit.

Katsuki didn’t know if Kirishima’s choice of seat had been intentional or not, but he knew better than to ask.

“I’m really glad you came”, Kirishima told him. “When I went to your bedroom, I was gonna try to talk you into coming here with me. I’m – I’m really glad you decided to do it on your own”.

Katsuki glared at him.

Even after everything, they all still expected him not to give a shit about Deku, huh?

Even after he was almost expelled trying to save the bastard.

They probably thought Katsuki did it to save himself, like Jirou had suggested.

That made him angrier. Angrier than he already was, angrier than he needed to be.

Kirishima probably noticed this, given what he said afterwards.

“You’re probably not really up to conversation right now, huh?”

Katsuki simply glared at him. That was all he needed to do.

“Ok, all right”, Kirishima gave him a tiny smile. “I’ll just keep you company, then”.

Katsuki scoffed.

“What? I’m not leaving you alone in a moment like this, dude”.

He sighed and crossed his arms above his chest. Kirishima simply sat there, silent, beside him.

Time passed.

The attention he seemed to have gotten when he arrived dissipated as the minutes ticked by. Everyone was too worried about Deku and his state to keep worrying about Katsuki, and he soon became a background character to the several people anxiously sitting at the waiting room.

Hah. He wanted to laugh at that irony.

He was a damn *extra*.

The minutes soon turned into an hour, and the closer the clock got to midnight, the tenser everyone grew. Katsuki didn't really know how all these people had found out about the countdown, but he was pretty sure one of the bastards who followed him into the sewers must have spilled the beans to everybody else.

It didn't really matter, now.

Earphone Girl suddenly materialized beside him, which would have startled him if he was anyone else. She had a fading bruise on her temple and a bandage around her right hand, but seemed fine otherwise. She was staring deep into Katsuki's eyes.

"What?", he asked her, sounding rather rude, after several seconds ticked by and she did nothing other than look at his face.

Jirou kept staring at him. She looked angry, but also concerned.

"How are you?", she settled for asking.

Katsuki scoffed, rolling his eyes and looking away from her.

"I mean, I know what happened. And I'm – well", she hesitated. "I'm sorry about your hearing".

Katsuki kept staring straight away, arms crossed above his chest.

"If there's anything I can do to help, just tell me, ok?"

He scowled at her.

"What could you fucking *do* about it? You're not a gear designer".

"Bakugou", Kirishima sighed tiredly from his other side, sounding disapproving.

"I know, but my quirk has to do with hearing", she pointed out. "Maybe we could make some study together, a research, and design a more suitable hearing aid for you".

He glared at her.

"Yours hurts, doesn't it?", she asked, giving him a sympathetic look. He hated it, and thus decided not to say anything.

It did hurt. Recovery Girl had told him it would take him some time to adapt and get used to it, that it was normal to be a bit uncomfortable with it for a while. Katsuki was pretty sure that the frequency with which he yanked the thing out of his ear instead of removing it carefully wasn't doing wonders for his adaptation, either.

But he didn't tell anyone about it, and he certainly wouldn't complain about it. He could handle a little pain. And he needed the damn aid to hear things properly, so he wasn't about to let it be taken away from him.

“Well… Let me know if you change your mind. I’m willing to help”, she added upon his silence.

Katsuki looked at her, allowing the annoyance to linger on his face, but nodded his thanks silently.

Instead of getting up and leaving, Jirou stayed there. It kind of bothered Katsuki, but since she was silent, he was ok with it.

Until she opened her mouth again.

(He immediately sighed).

“I’m sorry, Bakugou”, she said, and he didn’t look at her, or gave her any indication he had heard what she told him. “For… everything. I feel like I should have done more”.

“Yeah, like restraining the damn villain before he got away with Deku’s soul”, Bakugou grunted.

“Oh, man”, Kirishima sighed in a defeatist way.

Jirou, however, didn’t seem offended by that. Just upset.

“Yes. That”.

Silence again. It didn’t last long.

“I mean, we had no idea what was happening… We couldn’t see Midoriya, so we didn’t know he was being taken. We had all just woken up from that guy’s blow, and it looked like he was just trying to get away before the pros arrived. But still… We should have done something. *I* should have done something”.

“Yeah”.

Kirishima sighed again.

“It wasn’t your fault, Jirou”, the boy leaned forwards on his seat so that he could look at her, offering her a small smile. “Bakugou just sucks at comforting people”.

She returned Kirishima’s smile, though it didn’t quite reach her eyes.

“It’s ok, I don’t really –“

“It’s midnight”.

The announcement cut everyone off from any possible side conversation they could be having. Everyone stared at the person who said it – Todoroki, who was standing up and holding his phone. The cast was gone from his arm, Katsuki realized.

Katsuki glared at him. Todoroki stared straight back at Katsuki.

The room was silent.

This was it. Shinsou couldn't help, now.

If Deku's soul hadn't been returned by now…

Then he would die.

No one dared to speak a word in the following moments. Katsuki turned his phone back on so that he could check the time. 00:00. 00:10. 00:19.

00:28.

00:31.

00:47.

00:55.

01:02.

01:07.

01:09.

01:10.

01:16.

01:20.

01:24…

Recovery Girl finally arrived.

Everyone in the room immediately stood up in perfect synchrony, eyes fixed on the tiny woman in front of them. Wide eyes, worried eyes, anxious eyes. Uraraka looked like she was about to burst into tears, Iida's fisted hands were shaking slightly. Even Todoroki, the ice king, looked shaken, eyes slightly wide in anticipation. Katsuki didn't know what face he was making, but it wouldn't matter anyway – no one was looking at him. All eyes were fixed on Recovery Girl.

"Where is All Might?", she asked. She was wearing her regular clothes, and no longer the special gear she had been using to enter Deku's room. Katsuki didn't know what that meant.

"In the Special Room", Yaomomo was the one who replied after several tense seconds of silence, rational and compliant as always, even though she seemed as nervous as everybody else.

"Hm", was all the old woman said as she stepped further into the waiting room, leaning heavily on her cane.

She looked tired. She was headed to the Special Room, her footsteps and the ‘tap-tap-tap’ of her cane echoing across the otherwise silent room.

“Well?”, Kirishima was the one who broke the silence, properly translating the thought that was roaming in everyone’s minds. Recovery Girl turned on her heels to stare at him.

“I must speak to All Might first”, she announced, serious, and then continued walking.

“Is he alive?”

Everyone stared at Katsuki, Recovery Girl included.

Katsuki glared at her.

“Deku. Is he alive? Is his soul back?”

She looked at him. Her tiny eyes showed him something akin to sympathy.

“Yes, he will live”.

The room erupted into gasps, cheers, and all sort of celebratory sounds of relief and happiness. Kirishima hugged Jirou, Uraraka hugged Iida, everyone seemed to be hugging each other, and celebrating, because Deku would live, Deku was alive, Deku hadn’t died.

Katsuki continued to stare at Recovery Girl, who took the distraction provided by the pandemonium of the students to continue her track towards the Special Room and All Might. No one paid her any further mind – she had announced Deku would live, and that was all that mattered after such a tense wait for answers.

But there was something wrong. Katsuki could feel it.

He looked around the room, seeing the happy faces of his friends. Tears were in the eyes of many of them. Smiles, in all of them. Happiness, contaminating the room like a miasma.

Katsuki locked eyes with Todoroki. He could see, in blue and gray, the same suspicion, the same reluctance, the same doubt.

He knew Todoroki could see the same things etched in his own crimson eyes.

They were the only ones silent in a room full of cheering people, when, if anything, they were the ones supposed to be cheering the most.

Katsuki had never thought it possible that his first real connection with Icy Hot would turn out to be Deku, of all things.

Chapter End Notes

Happy Late Birthday, Bakugou

(The title comes from a Brazilian song of the same name and it means "The Taste of Anger")

Chapter 16: Interlude

Chapter Notes

> Brace yourself for a non-linear narrative in this chapter! Breaks in italics are set in the past.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

He woke up with the bright light from the sun sneaking into his dark bedroom through the slight open space between his binders. The streak fell right on the top of Katsuki's eyes, which made him squint and sight and feel annoyed first thing in the morning.

He opened his eyes, golden making crimson sparkle in the darkness. Before he could think too much about how tired he was feeling, he forced himself to sit up.

Funny how he used to think that, once this soul-quirk shit was over, he wouldn't feel so tired anymore. If anything, he was feeling even more so.

With a grumpy look on his face, Katsuki grabbed his phone in order to check the time. It was 8 a.m. Not bad, for a weekend. He preferred to wake up early even during the weekends so that he could make best of the extra hours he gave himself, but it would be stupid to deny that he could use the rest. *Should* use the rest.

At least that was what his therapist insisted on telling him, anyway. That he should take better care of himself. That he shouldn't be so harsh or demanding on himself. That he should give himself some time. Personally, Katsuki thought she was an idiot, because no one ever got to the top by taking breaks and sleeping the damn day away, but she *did* have a degree and a specialization on the subject. He wasn't dumb enough to overlook that, and, despite his personal opinions, he knew better than ignoring her just to be spiteful.

He would have done that, though. If these sessions had taken place two months before. He would have totally told her to go fuck herself and do the exact opposite of everything she told him, just out of spite.

He didn't know how to feel about that. The fact that he had changed so much in so little time, even if it wasn't evident, even if no one else could see it. In everyone's eyes, he was still the same arrogant, loud, angry asshole as ever, but when Katsuki looked at himself in the mirror, he was able to recognize how different he was from a month before. How different having Deku's soul around him had made him.

And he didn't know how to feel about that.

What he *did* know was that he couldn't let anyone know that he was actually doing as his therapist told him. He couldn't let anyone know about his weakness, about his increasing lack

of backbone. He couldn't let anyone know…

About…

What a fucking shitshow. He couldn't even bring himself to say the name.

He sighed, shoving the phone away and getting to the floor. Since he had woken up late, he had no time to waste. He did a series of pushups, face stern and closed off in concentration, before moving on to do bench presses with the weights he kept in his room, and all sorts of physical training to keep himself in shape. He tried not to think at all while he worked on his body – he didn't have the time or the patience to deal with distractions.

To deal with what had happened.

To deal with what was *still* happening.

To deal with the fact that he had watched everything firsthand. That he had… That he…

He shoved the weight away from himself suddenly and abruptly, as if the thing had personally offended him, and it fell heavily to the floor. He only half-heard the hard, thumping sound it made.

Katsuki sat up, breathing heavily and covering his sweaty face with his hands as he leaned his elbows on his knees.

He just breathed for a while, then he got to his feet and headed to the bathroom after taking just a few seconds to recompose.

He deserved a long, hot shower. He had earned it. It would be nice for him.

(He didn't feel like he deserved it, but he still stayed in it for a long while, allowing the scorching hot water to fall on his shoulders and run down his back until he was numb to all other feeling).

Eventually, once his fingers became too wrinkled and his shoulders became too senseless, he turned the water off and dried himself up with his towel. Then, he stepped out of the bathroom, naked, knowing there would be no one there to see him in that state.

It had been a month since Deku had gotten back to his body. It had been a *whole month*, and it had also taken Katsuki a while to get used to walking around naked again without feeling like there was a chance he was being observed, but he was finally there, now. It had been a whole fucking month; he had no reason to keep pretending Deku was still around somehow.

He wasn't. Katsuki knew he wasn't.

He sat by his studying desk and put his hearing aid on. Even though he had gotten used to some things over the course of the past month, some others were still taking their toll on him. *Exempli gratia*: the *fucking* hearing aids. When they weren't hurting him, they had that fucking feedback noise every time Katsuki tried to have lunch in peace and all the assholes around him kept being too loud at the cafeteria. Recovery Girl kept trying out new ways to

adjust it whenever he allowed himself to go to her infirmary, but more often than not, the comforts she offered were only temporary.

Most times, Katsuki found it easier not to wear the aid. He could still hear out of one ear, right? And it wasn't like he was missing out on anything too important by turning the thing off or removing it. None of his friends ever had anything of relevance to say, anyway. He was getting better at reading Aizawa Sensei's lips during lectures, even though he still turned the aid on during them. And Deku…

Well. Katsuki wasn't missing on anything by not wearing his hearing aid around him.

But it still bothered him, sometimes, not being able to hear things the same way he did before. He was mostly ok with it – from a very young age, Katsuki had already made peace with the fact that the superhero life often resulted on this type of consequence, especially with a quirk like his. Losing his hearing hadn't been that much of a shock, at first… Until he actually started to face the real consequences of the permanent damage he'd suffered. And, in rare moments when he actually listened to his therapist and allowed himself some simple comforts in life, he bothered to wear the hearing aid, even though there was no one around, even though he wasn't trying to hear anything in particular. He had never fucking thought that something as simple as his hearing would become such a commodity, and yet here he was. He was almost getting used to the pain, by now.

At the end of the day, it wasn't like he didn't deserve a little pain.

He turned his computer on and opened the page he had visited on the previous day. With a sigh, Katsuki pressed play on the video. Following the person on the screen, he tried to copy their movements and gestures and even took some notes on his notebook. This was one of the only ways he had found to actually distract himself and concentrate on something other than…

Well. Him. The little asshole.

Deku.

Katsuki shook his head, turning his attention back to his online sign language class.

They'd been helping him a lot, recently. UA was paying for actual, presential classes for him to learn sign language, but the online classes he had found on his own would only make his progress faster and easier. After all, Katsuki had always preferred to be self-taught – this way, he could get ahead of the losers competing against him *and* could impress his dumbass teachers at the same time. At least, that was how it had always been during school – how it had always been before UA.

Well. It wasn't really like Katsuki had a lot of competition on this, if he was being honest. No one was holding a "Who's the Deafest Student" contest – not that he would win, if there was one. His hearing wasn't even completely gone – his left ear still worked just fine. But if he *was* going to use sign language, for the moments when using his hearing aid wasn't a possibility, or for the moments when there was too much input for him to make do on his own, then he had to be the absolute *best* at it. Hence the online and the presential classes.

(And the fact that they helped distract him).

But nothing lasts forever, and none of the distractions he found ever worked for too long. He always ended up succumbing to the same spiral of thoughts, to the same stream of memories, to the same worries and concerns that had been taking over his mind for a month now.

Once he was done with the day's class, he shut the laptop closed and got to his feet, grabbing himself a change of clothes. He put on his best training outfit and grabbed his phone.

From: Bakugou Shonen

Gonna work out now. Same place as always.

He put on his shoes, shoved his phone into his pocket, and headed out of his room.

Sweat dripped dangerously from his palms.

Sweat dripped from his entire body, actually, but it was dangerous when it came from his palms. Still, he pushed himself to tighten his grasp on the ropes he was holding and keep dragging the car which they were attached to. Teeth gritted. A vein popping on his temple. His face all scrunched up in concentration.

But he forced himself to continue.

"Only one more block to go", All Might announced from where he was sitting on the top of the car Katsuki was trying to drag with his own hands.

"I know", Katsuki groaned through his tense jaw, trying to control his breathing and to keep an unfaltering hold to the rope. His whole body was beginning to protest – this was the fourth block he had managed to drag the car across, however slowly.

"You are doing amazing, Bakugou shonen", All Might encouraged him. He wasn't adding much weight to Katsuki's back, since he was sitting on the top of the car in his bony form – but still, every extra weight counted.

He wouldn't give up, though.

Once they arrived at the fourth street block, Katsuki let go of the rope and fell to his knees, finally allowing himself to pant and relax. All Might hopped off the car and approached him, kneeling on the floor beside him and placing a gentle, comforting hand on his shoulder.

“Did you really put Deku through all this?”, Katsuki ended up blurting out, because yeah, he had been training with All Might almost every day for a month, now, and that made him feel like he had an opening to ask that sort of question. They had grown closer, in a way – not in the same way All Might was close to Deku, but in a way that made Katsuki feel like he could trust the man to give him an honest answer, now.

All Might sighed, lowering his head slightly. Katsuki allowed himself to turn on his side and lie down on the floor as he struggled to catch his breath, which resulted on All Might sitting himself cross-legged beside him.

It took the man a while to answer. He looked like he was trying to find the proper words.

“Young Midoriya’s training was more rigorous, actually”, was what he settled for saying, which put an indignant frown on Katsuki’s face.

What the fuck? Why the hell did Deku work out harder than him? Was All Might taking things easy with him? Did he think Katsuki couldn’t handle the same amount of training as shitty Deku? Before he could voice his protests, All Might gave him a tired look and said, as if reading his mind: “And no, shonen, that was not because he was stronger than you. If anything, it was because he was weaker”.

Katsuki felt his face relax and only then realized he must have been scowling in anger, which was probably how All Might read his thoughts. Feeling slightly embarrassed but not enough to let it show, Katsuki averted the man’s eyes.

“His body was too slim and fragile for him to sustain One For All. If I passed my power to him in the way he was, with no training or preparation…”, All Might trailed off, sounding almost nostalgic.

And yeah, Katsuki knew exactly what he was talking about. He knew what would happen to Deku’s body if it sustained One For All while being all weak and fragile and bony and shit.

His organs would have collapsed. His bones would have been torn apart. He would have basically imploded.

He would have died. A gruesome death. A painful death.

Which was why Katsuki had taken One For All from him.

“I had to make sure his body would be prepared”, All Might continued. “I had to make him achieve a progress of years in months. You had your entire life to train and develop a strong muscular structure. He didn’t”.

Katsuki turned his head to meet All Might’s eyes.

“That is why your training is different”, the man concluded. “You don’t need to develop anything. Just maintain it”.

Katsuki stared at him in silence. Part of him wanted to scream and tell All Might to go fuck himself, even though he didn’t really know why. Part of him wanted to throw a tantrum and keep complaining about All Might’s reasons for training them differently, even though he knew his point made sense. Part of him just wanted to lie there, breathing and sweating and feeling the ache of his worn-out muscles, relishing on the sensation. Relishing on the adrenaline.

Relishing on the lightning coursing through his veins.

He closed his eyes, feeling a bit sick. He wanted to punch things and break things and tear things apart, because destruction was the best way for him to let his emotions out. It had always been.

Destructing his friendship with Deku. Destructing Deku’s dream. Destructing Deku’s chance at being a hero.

But none of those things were broken beyond repair, really. He had only borrowed Deku’s quirk, with every and all intention of giving it back as soon as possible. Deku’s dream had never been destroyed, not really, otherwise he wouldn’t have chased it and entered UA in the first place. As for their friendship…

Well. Katsuki didn’t really know about that. But he did know things were different. Ever since that damned quirk attached Deku’s soul to his, things were bound to never be the same again. For better or for worse.

For better or for worse.

Fuck. He still felt like punching something; now more than ever.

All Might was good at making him push and pull weight. But when it came to punching stuff? Not so much.

“Let’s call it a day”, Katsuki announced in a tone that left no space for a disagreement, even though he was the mentee, and not the mentor. He didn’t meet All Might’s eyes as he spoke, staring up at the blue sky looming widely above him instead, lying on his back.

“I was about to say the same, shonen”, All Might nodded his agreement, even though the words sounded fake to Katsuki’s ear.

“Hold him. Hold him!”

“Oh my god, what’s happening?!”

“Izuku! Oh my god! Izuku!”

“Hold him, Toshinori!”

“What is happening to him? What is wrong with him?! Izuku!”

“Deku…?”

“Midoriya!”

“Quick! It’s his quirk! Get his mother out of here! Bakugou, get in here, now! Todoroki, you too!”

“W-What…? But Izuku…”

“Now! We don’t have much time!”

“Mrs. Midoriya, I’m terribly sorry, but you need to come with me –“

“No! Can’t you see he’s in pain? He’s screaming! He needs me!”

“Bakugou! In here! Now!”

“He’s my son!”

“Mrs. Midoriya –“

“Toshinori, if you don’t hold him, his spine will snap in half, for god’s sake! Bakugou, you hold his legs! Todoroki, grab his arms! I need a nurse here! Nurse!”

“Izuku! Oh my god, Izuku!”

“What is going on?”

“Should we even be in here? What about the germs?”

“This is a life-or-death situation, boy! Don’t let go, Bakugou, pin him down. That’s it. Toshi, you too. Mrs. Midoriya, I understand your situation, but this could get ugly and you shouldn’t be in here to see this. Nurse!”

“But he’s my son!”

“And he’s my patient*! I’m trying to save his life!”*

“Is that – blood?”

“Oh my god… Oh my god! Oh my god! Izuku! Izuku!”

“What the fuck?! What the fuck is wrong with him?!”

“He’s crashing! Let me through!”

“Izuku! Do something, oh my god! Help him!”

“Deku!”

“Izuku!”

“Midoriya...”

“Hang in there, Midoriya shonen. Hang in there. You can do it. I am here. Everything will be fine, because… Because I... I am…”.

“Let me through! Clear the room!”

“No! Izuku! Get off me! Izuku!”

“Bakugou, go with her! Get her out and calm her down!”

“What about his legs?”

“Now!”

“What about his fucking *legs?”*

“Chiyo. Wait”.

“Izuku! Izuku! No, let me in! Let me back in!”

“Todoroki, you too! Out!”

“Chiyo. It can’t be me”.

A pause, longer than it should have been in a situation like this.

“What are you on about?”

“I can’t be me. I can’t handle it, either, not anymore. Not after the fight with All For One. I renounced it, and it has renounced me as well. It has to be him”.

Recovery Girl held her breath. They both stared at Katsuki before staring at each other again.

“There’s no time to decide, All Might. You have to be sure. He’s crashing, and we don’t have much longer”.

“I’m sure”.

“Absolutely?”

“Absolutely”.

A sigh.

“Todoroki. Out”.

Todoroki, who had been hesitating ever since the first command for him to leave, did as he was told, albeit reluctantly. He spared the trio and the wriggling Deku on the bed one final look before he opened the door, stepping out and allowing Inko’s desperate cries and sobs to fill the silence of the room before the room was sealed yet again behind him. Katsuki stayed exactly where he was.

“Do it. And make it quick”, Recovery Girl instructed, turning their back to them in order to grab several equipment she would need to tend to the whimpering, sobbing boy on the bed.

All Might approached Katsuki, letting go of Deku, who was trembling and twisting in pain. Katsuki stared at the symbol of peace with wide, frantic eyes. His face was pale and he was panting, confused as to why Deku was in such agony. All Might had never seen Katsuki look so shocked before, and it dawned painfully on him that, despite everything, the boy was only 16 years old after all. He was training to be a hero, yes, and the path in front of him would be full of horrors that he should grow accustomed to overtime. But he was still a boy. Still a kid, still too young to see such a gruesome scene.

But there was no other way.

And Katsuki didn’t think he had ever felt that scared before, fuck it if people would think he’s a coward. Deku’s eyes were open, only the whites showing, and there was blood bubbling from his lips, running down his chin, tinging his gritted teeth red. There was no fucking way Katsuki would be ok with watching a scene like that, even if he still hated Deku.

And now that he sort of, more-or-less, kind of liked the boy... Everything was even worse.

And, on the top of all that, Deku was whimpering. Grunting and whimpering and sobbing in agony. Just because he didn’t look like he had the strength to scream. Katsuki realized that his older self would have wanted to mock Deku for making such pathetic noises, but he reckoned that even if this had *taken place a year before, he wouldn’t have been able to find it in himself to laugh. Because Deku was emitting horrible gurgling noises, as if he was drowning in mud, and every pained breath he took sounded like a whistling wheeze, and Katsuki’s heart was thumping fast and hard inside his chest.*

“Bakugou shonen”, All Might called, and only then Katsuki realized his eyes were fixed on Deku’s suffering form, stuck in an almost trance-like state. He couldn’t even remember looking away from All Might and turning his head to stare at Deku in the first place. “Remember what I told you about One For All?”, All Might asked him, looking serious and concerned.

"Yes", Katsuki responded without missing a beat, not looking away from Deku's agonizing face. It felt almost like he couldn't move, not even if he wanted to.

"You have to take it".

And yeah, ok, that was what if finally took for him to break away from the trance. All Might's words almost had the same effect as hitting him in the face with a bucket of ice water. Katsuki blinked blankly for a split second before snapping his head towards the man with indignance etched all over his shining crimson eyes.

"Are you out of your fucking *–"*

"You won't take it forever. Just borrow it. It's killing Young Midoriya right now".

Katsuki stared at Deku's form on the bed again.

He did look like he was dying, blood tinging his lips and his cheeks red while he choked on it, eyes squeezed shut in agony. The crimson contrasted greatly with the whiteness of his face.

But still, Katsuki couldn't – he couldn't just take *it, he couldn't steal his damn quirk –*

"You said before he tried to pass it to you. That means you have his consent –", All Might continued.

"No, I fucking don't *–", Katsuki panted, furious, angry, because how the fuck could All Might even suggest something like that to him?! After everything he had done to Deku because he was quirkless? After the asshole finally got a damn fucking quirk in the first place?*

"You do. *You will be saving his life. His body's grown weak; he's lost muscular mass. He can't handle his power right now. You can give it back once he's recovered –"*

"No", Katsuki protested, interrupting the man. "No, I won't take his damn quirk. It's not mine".

"We don't have time to discuss this, shonen –"

Deku's heart monitor started to go crazy, making both of their heads snap in the direction of the bed. Deku had gone still, his scarred right arm rolled limply over the edge of the mattress, his head rolled lifelessly to the side.

"There is no time! It has to be now!", Recovery Girl shouted, her arms filled with equipment as she rushed towards her patient.

All Might grabbed Katsuki by the shoulders, turning him towards him and staring deep into his eyes with a serious, assertive look.

"It has to be you, shonen. He trusted you. He needs *you".*

"No –"

“You’re the only one of us who has his consent. If you don’t take it from him, it will kill him”.

“I’m losing him!”, Recovery Girl screamed as Deku began to flatline. Katsuki’s eyes widened in utter shock.

Deku was dying. His heart had stopped.

“Bakugou shonen!”, All Might roared, and Katsuki couldn’t remember ever hearing the man’s voice sound so powerful and authoritarian in his life, not even as he fought against the worst of villains.

He looked at Deku. His eyes were rolled back, his lips parted and coated in blood. His chest wasn’t moving.

His heart wasn’t beating.

Katsuki’s body responded before he could put much thought into it, before he could properly weight the consequences of what he was about to do. He shrugged away from All Might’s hands, surged forwards, grabbed Deku’s hair, yanked out a streak, shoved it into his mouth, and swallowed it.

He didn’t have the time or state of mind to think about how gross that was. All he could do was stare at Deku, dead on the hospital bed, bony and thin and eyes sunken into his skull-like face. This was the first time Katsuki had seen his body ever since the quirk accident, the first time he had seen it in a month, and now he understood why the boy had been so distraught upon seeing his own body.

He looked like a shell of himself. Like a ghost, like a skeleton, like a fucking goddamn corpse already.

Recovery Girl pushed Katsuki away from the bed with mindless strength and climbed on the top of Deku with a defibrillator. After two attempts that felt like they had lasted an eternity, she managed to urge a heartbeat back into the boy. Sighing in a relief that didn’t last too long, she started to give the nurses who had arrived all sorts of commands, all sorts of instructions, but Katsuki couldn’t hear them – not only because his hearing was now impaired, but because he was in shock. That was the only way to describe it. He was in pure, utter shock.

All Might was holding him and talking to him, but he couldn’t hear the words. All he could do was stare at Deku, who was lying still on the bed, who still looked dead despite of the heart monitor telling them otherwise. The crimson escaping his lips matched the crimson of Katsuki’s eyes, and he coughed up pitifully, painfully, still choking on his own blood as he was brought back to life.

And Katsuki had never felt so young, had never felt so vulnerable, had never felt so painfully aware of his own mortality than when he stared down at Deku on that moment, because Deku had just died, for less than a minute, yes, but Katsuki could have lost him forever and the last he would have ever seen of the boy would be… this. No more comments during class. No

more compliments and praises. No more rivalry and competition. No more green eyes and soft smiles. No more 'Kacchan's, no more 'matte yo!'s, no more 'sugoi's, no more Deku.

The thought scared him. He hated it that it did, but it scared him.

"I need you to get out of here", he thought he heard Recovery Girl say through the blurry layer of shock that was coating his senses. "He's already been exposed enough. You shouldn't be here without the suits –"

"Come on, shonen", All Might's voice echoed. "We need to go".

"Did it work?", Katsuki heard himself say, but couldn't remember giving his brain the command to do so. His eyes were glued to Deku, and he turned his head to look at the boy's still form over his shoulder as All Might pushed him towards the door.

"Come on".

"Did it work*?"*

"We won't know for a while. But he's alive, and Recovery Girl needs to work –"

"Is it with me now? Did I take it?", he looked at All Might, eyes still wide, breath still caught in his throat.

All Might squeezed his shoulder, looking pale.

"Did I take it from him?"

"You saved his life*".*

Katsuki gasped, face torn in a mixture of angry and horrified. He didn't feel any different after taking Deku's quirk – all he could feel was his racing heart and his constricted lungs.

Deku had died. He had fucking flatlined.

He had fucking died. He was coughing up blood. He was fucked up, and Katsuki had taken his quirk, and he was fucked up. And he had died.

All Might led him out of the hospital room and it was locked behind them, muffling Recovery Girl's commands to Katsuki's already impaired hearing. Todoroki was waiting outside, and for what was probably the first time ever, he looked actually concerned – even more so the moment he spotted Katsuki. He grabbed Katsuki's shoulder and asked him a series of questions, multicolored eyes staring deep into crimson, but all Katsuki could do in return was stare at his face with a blank look that was anything but angry, for once; thoughts of blood and death impregnating his brain and the memory of the constant, high-pitched sound Deku's heart monitor gave as he flatlined mixing with the ringing of Katsuki's ears to the point where he couldn't tell them apart.

"His body grew weak because of the past month. He lost a lot of muscular mass. The reason why he didn't collapse earlier was because One For All is a quirk of the soul, not of the body. You will remember that, when you were trying to convince us that you could see Midoriya shonen, I asked you to make him activate his quirk, which he successfully did. You will also find that One For All takes a while to kick in – usually, a couple of hours, but it can take longer, depending on the case".

Katsuki stared at the floor in silence.

All Might eyes were glued to him, waiting for a response. When none came, he sighed.

"In Midoriya shonen's case it… When his soul was returned, it took his body a while to catch up with everything, just in the same way it took a while for you to access One For All after you took it. Recovery Girl noticed there was something wrong when she came to fetch me, but by the time she arrived at the hospital room, his organs were already collapsing beneath the strength of that power. He had no more muscles or health to endure such a force".

Katsuki stayed silent.

"I understand this may have not been your choice, Bakugou shonen, and I am sorry for forcing you into this. But if I had taken his quirk, the same would have happened to me. I am weakened, and I wouldn't have been able to pass the quirk back on to him in case I died while sustaining its power. It had to be you".

Katsuki's leg started to bounce. He continued to avoid looking at All Might, and his facial expression was turning more into an angry glare than anything else.

"You can give it back to him once he is well again".

Katsuki scoffed, the first sound he made ever since All Might called him for that reunion. Ever since All Might finally accepted to talk to him, after the hellish night Katsuki had gone through.

"This was only a temporary solution to keep Young Midoriya from dying. Which is what you did. You saved his life. Now, he has a chance to recover on his own, to get better –"

"Has the fever gone down?"

All Might paused, surprised to have earned a response from the boy.

"I'm afraid not".

“Because we infected him”.

All Might sighed.

“It was necessary. He was dying – Recovery Girl needed us there. There was no time to put on protective suits in such a moment of crisis”.

Katsuki scoffed again.

“So there’s a chance he’ll still die”.

Silence.

“We are trying to have a more optimistic outlook than that”.

“I’m not talking about hopes and shitty dreams, I’m talking about facts”, Katsuki glared at All Might. “Statistics. There’s a chance he’ll still die, isn’t there?”

All Might gave him a sad look.

“Yes”.

“And if that happens, then what? I become the new bearer of One For All? The new heir to All Might’s power? The new fucking symbol of peace*?”*

All Might bowed his head.

“I do not think it should come to this –“

“Well, I do”, Katsuki interrupted. “Because one fucking month ago, I didn’t fucking think I’d be crying at Deku’s deathbed while he fucking convulsed and screamed in pain as a direct result of taking a fucking blow for me, I didn’t think I'd get glued to his soul, I didn’t think I'd ever give a shit about him, and yet here we fucking are”.

All Might stared at him.

“So I don’t think anything is that impossible anymore. And this”, Katsuki gestured at his own body, rage and anger making his hands tremble. “I don’t fucking want this. It’s Deku’s*; it’s not mine”.*

“Bakugou shonen –“

“It’s not mine*. I didn’t earn it”.*

All Might gave him that sad look again.

“He chose you”.

Katsuki scoffed.

“He didn’t have a fucking choice*. It was either me, or letting your legacy die with him. I was the only one he could have passed it to”.*

“Precisely”.

Silence.

All Might sighed, crossing his hands and placing them atop his lap.

“Shonen, I honestly do not know what it will take for you to accept that, even more than me or anyone, you *are the person Midoriya shonen holds the most admiration, love, devotion, and reverence for”.*

Katsuki stared at him without saying anything for long, silent moments. He wasn’t sure what he could say in response to that.

He wasn’t sure how he felt about that.

He angrily stood up from the couch at All Might’s room and barged out.

He dodged Kirishima’s kick with mastery and rolled on the floor away from his friend’s fist, which came flying towards him with little to no response time. Before Kirishima could regain his footing, Katsuki swiped his feet from beneath him using his legs and got to the top of his friend, restraining both Kirishima’s hands above the boy’s head and pressing a forearm against his neck. Kirishima tapped his restrained hands to the floor as best as he could in surrender and Katsuki let go of him without missing a beat, immediately getting to his feet again and walking away to the farthest edge of the mat in preparation for their next round.

“Geez, man”, Kirishima panted, taking a hand to his neck and still lying down on the floor. “You’re on *fire* today”.

“Get up”, Katsuki instructed simply, sharply, objectively.

“Gimme a minute”, Kirishima said, sounding like he was having trouble catching his breath. “Losing to you five times in a roll isn’t doing wonders for my morale”.

“I don’t give a shit”, Katsuki said, stretching his arms back and turning on his heels in order to glare at his friend from the distance. “Get up, or I’ll come at you while you’re still on the fucking floor”.

“That’s not fair play”, Kirishima groaned as he turned on his side and pushed himself to his feet.

Katsuki immediately charged at him, but it was Kirishima’s time to dodge. Hardening himself up with his quirk, he blocked two of Katsuki’s consecutive attacks with his arms, taking the chance to kick his friend’s stomach and send him flying a few meters back. Instead of colliding with the floor, Katsuki rolled gracefully on it and immediately regained his footing, ready to charge at Kirishima again.

Instead of waiting for Katsuki to attack so that he could block, as he had been doing so far, Kirishima charged at his friend, assuming a more confrontative stance. Katsuki easily grabbed hold of Kirishima’s wrist, however, which was aiming for a punch, and then he grabbed Kirishima’s forearm with his free hand, using the grip to flip the boy over his shoulder and onto the floor, where Kirishima collided harshly on his back.

However, Kirishima didn’t allow himself to be defeated and grabbed a hold of Katsuki’s ankle, pulling it and making the explosive boy lose balance and collapse on his side. He took advantage of the distraction to get atop of Katsuki and restrain his arms, much in the same way Katsuki had done to him just a few moments before.

“Five to one”, Kirishima smiled triumphantly from where he was holding Katsuki’s arms behind his back. “Looks like I’m catching up with –“

Before he could finish the sentence, Katsuki set off a pair of explosions from his hands in order to shove Kirishima away from him. It worked – Kirishima yelped and let go in surprise, releasing Katsuki’s arms – but the loud, disruptive noise caused a horrible feedback on Katsuki’s hearing aid and he flinched, hissing loudly and taking a hand to his ear.

He could see, from the corner of his eyes, Kirishima approaching him on the mat with a friendly gesture and a worried face as Katsuki cringed in discomfort, but didn’t look at his friend as he turned the device off and took it out of his ear, cursing under his breath and still hissing.

“Hey, man. You ok?”, Kirishima asked him, placing a friendly hand on his shoulder. Katsuki shrugged it off, feeling ashamed and embarrassed.

“Fine”, he grunted in a feral way, shoving the hearing aid into his pocket and walking away from the fighting mat. Kirishima took that as a sign that their sparing session was over and followed him out, grabbing themselves two bottles of cool water and tossing one to Katsuki, who grabbed it easily and with indifference.

“That thing still hurting you?”, Kirishima nodded at Katsuki’s pocket, where he had stored the hearing aid, before opening his bottle and taking a long gulp of water. Katsuki huffed out a breath.

“Nah. It’s just the damn feedback”, Katsuki grunted before gulping his own water. Kirishima frowned at him.

“Really?”

“Hm”.

“You should talk to someone about that, bro. You got a loud quirk; the hearing aid can’t keep giving you feedback like that. Especially during battle or something”.

“You’d think that with modern technology, some fucker with nothing to do would have fucking sorted this shit out already”, Katsuki commented, sitting down on a chair beside the mat in order to give himself a break. He had gotten out from the training with All Might straight to the training with Kirishima, and it wouldn’t be an overstatement to say he was tired as *fuck*.

“Maybe try and talk to that girl who makes the gadgets?”, Kirishima suggested, shrugging and stepping closer to his friend. “She looks like she’s good at that sort of thing, from what I’ve heard. I think her name is Hatsume Mei? You know, the one from the Sports Festival, the chick who teamed up with Mido–“

Kirishima stopped himself before he could actually say the name, but the damage was done. Katsuki had tensed up, the water bottle being squeezed in his grasp as he glared up at the floor in front of him.

“Sorry”, was all Kirishima had the guts to say, voice small and guilty.

Katsuki huffed out another breath and shifted his gaze, taking a final gulp of water before closing the bottle and putting it down on the floor. Kirishima was staring at him, clearly awkward, but Katsuki pretended not to see it.

Silence stretched on as Katsuki picked up his shoes and began to put them on.

“So, uh...”, Kirishima tried as Katsuki resumed tying his shoes up and stood up from the chair, desperate to change the subject or at least make conversation. “We’re done for today?”

Katsuki gave his friend one simple, pointed glare before picking his bag up and throwing it above his shoulder. He started walking towards the exit of the gym.

“The hell does it look like, fuckface?”, he snarled. Kirishima sighed, grabbing his own shoes and racing after Katsuki, since he knew well his friend wouldn’t slow down or wait for him to put his socks on.

“I’ve been meaning to talk to you about that, actually”, Kirishima said as he caught up with Katsuki, holding his shoes in one hand and his bag on the other. Katsuki didn’t turn his head to face him properly, but rather gave Kirishima a sideways glare.

“About what?”, he asked sharply, his tone already indicating he wasn’t exactly feeling patient on that moment. Which only served to increase Kirishima’s guilt for bringing up Midoriya, since Katsuki had been doing fine until he mentioned that name.

But he had put this conversation off for too long. They needed to talk about what had happened. About what *was* happening.

“You know. The whole...”, Kirishima hesitated, not sure what his friend’s reaction would be – probably sour. “The whole... Midoriya… *thing*”.

Katsuki's lips formed a thin line and his face immediately closed off into an even angrier expression.

“Have you been visiting him?”

“No”.

Kirishima bit his lower lip.

“Why not?”

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“Why the *fuck* would I?”

Kirishima sighed. He hated it when Katsuki was purposefully difficult.

“C’mon, man”, was all he said in response. Katsuki sighed in profound annoyance beside him.

“I got no reason to go visit the nerd. He hasn’t woken up; what the fuck am I supposed to do there? Stare at his dumb sleeping face and play solitaire with myself?”

Kirishima sighed again.

“I don’t know. Recovery Girl says it’s good if we talk to him, might encourage him or something”.

“Well, there are a lot of idiots talking to him, so I don’t have to bother”.

Kirishima looked at his friend.

“It’s just... You know, after everything you guys went through –”

“Quit the crap talk, Shitty Hair”, Katsuki interrupted, annoyed, in a warning tone that left no place for a discussion. But Kirishima wasn’t intimidated.

“I mean it, Bakugou. You should at least pay him a visit”.

“Why the *fuck* do you care if I do?”, Katsuki snapped his head abruptly towards his friend, angry. “What difference does it even fucking make?”

Kirishima stared up at him with expressive eyes and an almost guilty expression.

“I think it would be good for you”, he settled for saying. Katsuki snorted a harsh puff through his nose.

“It’d be good for me if you shut your damn mouth for once”, he snarled.

“You’ve been moping, man”.

“I haven’t been fucking *moping* –”

“And even though you’re doing better at the anger thing, you’re still stressed out. And we know the reason why”.

“It’s time you stop talking, Kirishima”.

“No one can even say his name near you and you get like this. It's not good for you, man”.

“Final fucking warning”.

“I was wrong”.

Katsuki stopped walking and glared at his friend. They were inside the dorm building, now, but the common room was peacefully empty and there was nobody around to overhear their conversation.

Kirishima sustained his gaze for a while before shaking his head and bowing it with frustration.

“Look. I really don’t know how to talk about this with you. I don’t even know if you *know* what I'm talking about”.

“I clearly fucking don’t”, Katsuki pointed out, crossing his arms above his chest.

“See?”, Kirishima gesticulated with his hands. “I just - I don’t know how to tell you this, man”.

“Tell me *what*?”, Katsuki insisted, confused and irritated.

“That I was *wrong*. About that stuff I told you a month ago. That you only – that you only liked Midoriya because of the empathic bond. That wasn’t true”.

Katsuki glared at him with the fury of a thousand suns. Kirishima didn’t allow himself to coward beneath the angry gaze.

“It’s just – after everything, man, after these two months with and without him, do you really –”, he hesitated, shaking his head again. “I mean. It’s not manly to keep pretending, you know?”

“Pretending *what*?”, Katsuki growled, anticipation making him tighten his hands into fists.

Kirishima sighed.

“That you don’t care about him, when it’s obviously eating you up”.

Katsuki's teeth became exposed to the chilly air of the room as he snarled at Kirishima.

“Sorry if I crossed a line here, man”, the boy raised one hand in front of himself as an indicator of peace. “I know we don’t usually talk about this stuff, but I think it’s about time we did so. Because you’re my best friend, and I'm worried about you, I'm really worried”.

“You don’t have to fucking *worry* about me”, Katsuki spat. “I’m not the one who’s lying half-dead in a hospital bed”.

Kirishima sighed, bowing his head again.

“Dude, I –”

“This conversation is over. I’m going to my room”, Katsuki announced, turning on his heels and walking away.

“Bakugou”.

Katsuki didn’t stop walking.

“*Bakugou*”, Kirishima called again, not following him, but rather standing in the middle of the common room. “I’m not sparring with you anymore”.

Katsuki stopped on his tracks, turning to face Kirishima from where he was standing at the bottom of the stairs.

“This is like the *least* healthy way you could deal with this, man. You can’t just punch your emotions out of this one like you always do. And I know I normally indulge you because I’m the only one who can take it, in all the meanings of the word, but... Until you figure this feedback thing out, and until you actually *deal* with everything that’s going on, I'm…”, he shook his head again, looking hesitant but determined. “I’m sorry, bro, but I’m not going to let you use me as your stress relief. You gotta face this headfirst, man. You gotta – you gotta do something. You gotta cope in a healthy way, you know? And I'm here for you, and you have all my support, but I won’t let you use me as a punching bag anymore, even if you’re not actually hurting me. This isn’t good for *you*”.

And irrational sense of rage coursed through Katsuki’s veins as he stared at Kirishima in scorching silence, his hands threatening to pop anytime soon.

“Suit yourself, asshole”, was what he said through gritted teeth.

He made his way back to his room without looking back to see the guilt etched in Kirishima’s eyes.

List of things that make me angry

Kirishima

He threw the list against the wall and took another shower.

"Eat up".

Katsuki glared up at Four Eyes.

"What the fuck are you now, my fucking baby sitter?"

"It is one of my duties as class representative to make sure all my colleagues are faring well and taking care of themselves. Plus, since you are being so childish, a baby sitter wouldn't go amiss".

Katsuki shoved the bowl of soba away, just as rudely as he had intended, and glared up at Iida. He scoffed.

"Didn't know you knew how to fucking use sarcasm".

Iida frowned.

"I wasn't using sarcasm".

Katsuki raised an eyebrow at him and snarled.

"Then what the fuck did you mean by that, you four-eyed piece of nerdy *shit*?", he growled, leaning forwards on the table. Iida seemed unaffected by his temper.

"It seems you still have a long way to go until you're cleared out of anger management", he commented, but there was no teasing in his voice – just blunt honesty and a hint of concern.

"Listen here, you *fucker* –"

"Bakugou-kun. I am not here to pick up a fight", Iida raised a hand at him.

"Then what the *fuck* is up with all these sassy-ass comments, huh?", Bakugou scoffed. Iida had the decency to look embarrassed at the accusation, bowing his head slightly and pushing his glasses up the bridge of his nose.

"Forgive me if I came off as rude. Sometimes, I can be too blunt, as Uraraka-san insists on telling me. But what I mean", he carefully grabbed the soba bowl and pushed it back towards Katsuki on the table, slowly. "Is that this is a peace offer".

Katsuki glared at the bowl, then at Iida. As if he could ever fucking find *peace*.

“From Todoroki-kun and me”, Iida added, nodding at the bowl. Katsuki immediately snarled.

“No way in *hell* I’m gonna eat anything that half-and-half bastard offers me”.

Iida sighed.

“The fuck are you really here for, Class Rep?”, Katsuki asked, leaning back on his chair and placing his feet on the table in a way that was purposefully disrespectful, before Iida could offer anymore comments about the fucking *soba*.

Iida set his hands on the table in front of him, looking around as if to check if they were being overheard. The cafeteria was mostly empty, since it wasn’t lunch or dinner time, and there was no one sitting near them (Katsuki had chosen that fucking table for a *reason*).

“Midoriya will need all the support he can get once he wakes up”, Iida settled for saying, and yeah, as soon as Katsuki spotted the nerdy face of one of Deku’s closest friends sitting in front of him while he fucking minded his own business, he knew *exactly* what the conversation topic would be.

That didn’t mean the name didn’t feel like a punch to his fucking gut, though. Not that he would admit it.

“Good for him”, was what Katsuki offered as a response, petty on purpose.

“That includes you”, Iida added without missing a beat.

Katsuki snorted, giving the boy a humorless smirk. If he didn’t feel like talking about Deku to his closest friends, why the *fuck* would he talk about it to a guy with whom he’d barely exchanged two words in his entire life?

“Yeah, it sure as fuck does. Because Deku and I have always been so close, haven’t we?”, he commented, poison dripping from his tone. Iida didn’t seem affected.

“No. But you have grown close in the past month”.

Katsuki glared at him in silence.

“You don’t know shit”.

“Indeed, I don’t”, Iida admitted, the seriousness of his face never faltering.

He looked tired. It was a bit weird, honestly. Maybe he was losing sleep over Deku’s bony ass just as much as Katsuki was.

Well. As fucking *if*.

“I will be honest with you”, Iida continued with that usual sternness that was a constant in his personality. “I was against coming to talk to you. Uraraka-san was neutral about it, since she

is busy worrying about Midoriya-kun's recovery process. Todoroki was the one who insisted".

Katsuki's hands tightened into fists. What the fuck.

"Well, it *had* to be the fucking bastard, hadn't it –"

"He did not tell me his reasons for thinking your presence will be any good for Midoriya-kun, especially in the fragile state he will be in once he wakes up. But he was insistent about it, and after everything we've been through… I trust his judgement".

Katsuki scoffed. The last thing he wanted to feel towards Todoroki was *gratitude* – and the least the bastard could fucking do was keep his mouth shut and not tell anyone about *that* night, right? –, but he couldn't deny that, despite the humiliation that came along with the feeling, that was precisely his sentiment right at that moment.

Well, one of his sentiments. The most prominent one was rage.

"Why the fuck didn't he come here himself, then?", he scoffed. Iida tilted his head to the side as if judging Katsuki for asking that question.

"You and I both know what your reaction would have been if Todoroki-kun came to you asking for favors".

"Is that what you're fucking asking me, then?"

"I do not see this as a favor", Iida shrugged. "As for you… I am not so sure".

Katsuki scoffed.

"What I mean to say is", Iida continued after a few seconds of awkward silence. "I don't know what happened to you and Midoriya-kun during the past month, but I can tell that something has changed in your relationship with one another. For the better, I would hope".

Katsuki scoffed again.

"And what I *do* know is that, despite your behavior and your treatment of him, Midoriya-kun has *always* cared about you".

Katsuki's jaw tensed up. Why the fuck did people insist on telling him all about Deku's admiration for him? Why the fuck did they assume he wanted to fucking know, after everything?

"And, despite my opinion on this, or Todoroki's opinion… I cannot imagine him being happier than if you went visiting him once he's awake".

All right. Red alert. This was getting too much. This was getting to dangerous places.

Katsuki suddenly slammed one fist on the table, making the soba bowl rattle. Iida didn't flinch, but he did look surprised.

Katsuki leaned forwards on the table, glaring and snarling at Iida in an almost animalistic way.

“Fuck off”, he growled through gritted teeth.

“Bakugou-kun –“

“I said *fuck off*”.

Iida stayed where he was, serious.

“No”.

Katsuki scoffed, raising an eyebrow.

“The *fuck* did you say?”

“I said no, Bakugou-kun. I am here on Midoriya-kun’s behalf. It will cost you nothing to set your own ego aside for a few minutes and pay him a visit just to cheer him up, after you were the only person he could communicate with for a month”.

Nothing? It would cost him *nothing*? Seeing Deku’s bony fucking face and knowing very well the reason he looked like that was because he threw his stupid ass in front of Katsuki in order to save his life? Seeing the pale green of his stupid hair, seeing the way his arms and legs had lost months-worth of muscular mass?

Hearing the way his voice would crack as he said his name? Seeing the way his lips would curl up into a smile the exact moment he saw him, because the bastard doesn’t care enough about himself to realize that he could have fucking died for Katsuki, *because* of Katsuki, since he had thrown his life away in the blink of an eye for him?

How the fuck could Katsuki look Deku in the eyes knowing that he had stolen his fucking quirk from him? Knowing that One For All now coursed through his veins, and not his?

Knowing that he had taken everything Deku could give him and more, not only in the past month, but throughout all their lives?

“Don’t talk about shit you don’t know”, he settled for saying, pushing himself to his feet and ready to stand up. He had to fucking leave before he punched Iida in the face, before he ended up doing something stupid that resulted on his actual, permanent expulsion.

One of Iida’s hand crossed the distance separating them on the table and grabbed his wrist before he could properly stand up.

“Bakugou-kun. At least eat your soba”, he said. Katsuki scoffed. “As a peace offer”.

He glared at Iida, halfway standing, halfway sitting.

“Do I look like I want fucking *peace*?”

Do I look like I can *have fucking peace?*

“No. But I don’t think what you want is the priority in a situation like this”.

Katsuki yanked his arm away from Iida’s grasp, still snarling.

“Your pep talk fucking *sucks*”.

“It’s not a pep talk. It is the truth. I don’t really understand why, but Midoriya-kun cares for you, and he will need you there with him for his recovery. You are the one who was with him before he was taken by the villain. Coming to you and asking you, of all people, to be there for him isn’t my favorite option either, believe me, but I’m sure it will be good for him, even if I don’t agree with it”.

Katsuki glared at him. Iida stood up from his chair unceremoniously, objectively. He gave Katsuki a serious look.

“I will not argue with you over this. I have already presented my point and insisted enough. The choice is up to you, now”.

He turned on his heels to leave before stopping himself and turning to face Katsuki again.

“Eat the soba. You look like you could use it”.

“Why the fuck are you even talking to me about this shit now?”, Katsuki blurted out from the table before Iida could actually walk away. The boy stared at him with a neutral expression.

“Because they are taking Midoriya-kun off sedation tomorrow morning. He will probably regain consciousness by the end of the day”.

Katsuki stared at Iida in silence and only looked away from the spot where he had been standing once the boy was out of the otherwise empty cafeteria.

He sat there by himself in silence, thinking about everything Iida had told him and all the possible implications of his words and requests.

He grabbed the soba bowl.

“Kacchan - K-K-Kacchan...”

“Shh. Easy, boy”.

“Where is he? Is he safe? Is he ok?”

“He’s right here, Young Midoriya”.

“I’ve already told you a hundred times, shitty Deku. I'm here. Stop breaking a fucking sweat over it”.

“Kacchan?”

“Yeah. It’s me”.

“And you’re ok?”

“Yeah. You're the one who’s fucked up, so shut the hell up and go back to sleep”.

“C-Can’t. It – It hurts”.

“Yeah, I know. But you gotta sleep if you plan on getting your ass off that bed anytime soon”.

“I’m burning, Kacchan. I’m - I’m b-b-burning, please, don’t burn me again, it hurts, don’t - don’t b-burn me –”

“I’m not burning you, Deku”.

“P-Please – Agh, I – Please, Kacchan, it hurts –”

“I need to sedate him. He's too out of it. It's impairing his recovery”.

“Are you sure?”

“We don’t have many options left. The best thing to do is to give his body time to rest and heal. Rushing things with my quirk will do nothing for him – he barely has anything left to give, and the stress is making him worse. He needs to save all the energy he can”.

“And how long until he heals?”

“There’s no way to tell. But having him fidgeting around and being this disturbed will do more harm than good, and certainly give him more days in here”.

“K-Kacchan? Where is he? Is he ok? Did I save him? Is he hurt?”

“Shut the hell up, Deku. I'm here. I'm not leaving. Quit that crap”.

“Kacchan?”

“God fucking damn it”.

“It is for the best, Bakugou. I will call his mother and All Might in so that they can speak to him before I sedate him, and then we’ll have to leave him be for a while”.

Katsuki's lips formed a thin, displeased line.

“Whatever”.

“Keep placing those damp cloths on him to lower his temperature. The antibiotics will take a while to kick in. I'll be right back”.

And with that, Recovery Girl was gone.

“Kacchan, please – d-don’t - don’t leave”.

Katsuki sighed, picking a damp cloth from the small bowl at the bedside stand and placing it on the top of Deku’s burning forehead.

“I’m not leaving, you idiot”.

“I d-don’t wanna die alone”.

“Tch. You’re not fucking dying. Stop being so dramatic”.

“It hurts”.

Katsuki glared down at him, finally meeting the boy’s eyes for the first time ever since his arrival. Deku's eyes were glassy and unfocused, completely disoriented in his feverish and pained state. It looked like he was staring straight through Katsuki, unable to quite recognize him, which honestly freaked him the fuck out, because Deku’s eyes were always focused and sharp, even when he was distracted and rambling like an idiot.

But that sort of confusion was only to be expected after Deku almost died and several of his organs collapsed. Recovery Girl had had to resort to using her quirk in all its might in order to keep Deku from kicking the bucket, and while she did manage to make him stable enough to survive, his body was still weak as fuck and in need of intensive care – after all, his soul had only been returned a mere day before.

“I know”, Katsuki settled for saying, trying to mask the angry guilt he was feeling from his voice.

Because he did. He knew what sort of fucking pain Deku was feeling. He had never experienced it, but he could imagine it. And he knew Deku wouldn’t be so out of it if his body wasn’t dealing with so much at once.

“I’m sorry”, Izuku squeezed his eyes shut in discomfort.

Katsuki scoffed.

“The fuck for?”

“I know you d-don’t like me, but I - I really d-don’t wanna die alone, I – ...Can – C-can you please tell her, tell my mom I'm sorry”.

“Deku, shut the fuck up. You're not making any sense”.

“I’m sorry, I'm so s-sorry”.

“It’s not your fault, dumbass. You just need to shut up and lie still, or Recovery Girl will knock you out”.

“I - I don’t wanna b-be alone again –”

“You’re not alone. I'm here with you, are you thick in the head or what? Can’t you fucking see me standing right here?”

“I’m sorry”, Deku reached out to grab Katsuki’s hand with the little strength he had (which wasn’t much) and squeezed it tightly, his eyes glassy and unfocused and wide, manic by fever. “Mom, I'm sorry. Mom, I'm sorry. Please, forgive me, mom”.

“I’m not your fucking mom”.

“All Might. A-All Might – All Might, All M-Might, I'm sorry, All Might –”

“Deku, stop it”, he yanked his hand away from the boy’s weak grasp, replacing the fear he was feeling with anger (even though his therapist’s voice kept yelling in his head that this wasn’t the best choice). “You're freaking me the fuck out”.

“Please, I'm sorry, All Might. Forgive me, All Might”.

“I’m not All fucking Might, Deku. I’m Katsuki”.

“Huh?”

“It’s Katsuki. It's not All Might”.

“K-K-Kat...?”

“Katsuki”, he repeated with impatience.

Upon the empty, glassy look that bore no recognition in Deku's feverish eyes, Katsuki sighed.

Fuck that. Deku was too out of it; he probably wouldn’t even remember the conversation in the first place. It was worth a shot.

“It’s Kacchan. Not All Might”.

“K-Kacchan?”

“Yeah, you little asshole. I'm here, your mom’s not mad, All Might’s not mad. No one is fucking mad, so just chill the hell out and go to sleep, ok? You’re pissing me off”.

“Kacchan? You're r-really here?”

“What the fuck do you think, dumbass? I swear to god, just close your damn eyes and rest”.

“You’re ok?”

“Yes, Deku, for the thousandth fucking time, I'm ok”.

“Why are you wearing that? Are we in space?”

“No, dipshit. I'm wearing this because your immune system is fucked up and you’re already losing what little brains you had left because of the shitty infection you caught”.

“I’m - I'm sick?”

“It fucking seems so”.

“What’s happening?”

“We were attacked, but you’re fine now. You just need to catch some sleep before Recovery Girl puts you in a fucking coma”.

“W-What? Attacked?”

“Yeah”.

“And y-you’re ok?”, he frowned in actual concern.

“Holy fucking shit, you goddamn fucking idiot, stop asking the same fucking question a million fucking times over! If you don’t go to sleep right now, I'll knock you the fuck out myself!”

Deku’s eyes became watery and his face scrunched up in sadness and confusion.

“K-K-Kachan... I’m s-sorry... I didn’t mean – I didn’t mean to m-make you m-mad".

Katsuki sighed, lowering his head. Deku had tears rolling down his cheeks.

Guilt blossomed in his heart with the fury of a star and Katsuki hated himself on that moment. What a fucking wimp he was for feeling bad for making Deku cry.

What a fucking monster he was for making Deku cry.

He had really gotten soft.

“Fuck, shit – stop crying”, he told Deku, sighing heavily and adjusting the damp cloth on the boy’s forehead as gently as he could – which wasn’t really gentle, but Izuku was too out of it to notice. “Look. I didn’t mean to yell at you. My bedside manner sucks and you're just really scaring the shit out of me right now, so you need to go the fuck to sleep before you make yourself worse, ok? Can you shut your trap and close your eyes?”

“Promise?”

“What?”

“You won’t leave? Promise?”

“Yeah, I fucking promise, Deku”.

“All right”.

He closed his eyes, only to open them again five seconds later, looking even more out of it than before.

“All... M-Might?”

“He’s not here. He'll arrive soon. Go to sleep”.

“I just d-did”.

“You closed your eyes for five fucking seconds, that’s not sleeping”.

“What...?”

“Fucking damn it”.

“All… Might?”

“He’s not here yet, Deku. Go to sleep”.

“I’m sorry, All Might. I - I tried...”

“Deku, I swear to fucking –”, he stopped himself, trailing off with a sigh.

“All Might, I'm sorry”.

“I’ve already told you I'm not All Might, shitty nerd. It's Katsuki”.

“Huh?”

“It’s Kacchan, dipshit”.

“Kacchan?”

“Yeah. Will you shut up now?”

“Kacchan”, Deku surged forwards with urgency in his wide eyes and grabbed the front of Katsuki's shirt with the little strength he had left – which wasn’t much, given the fact that he could barely even move from the bed. The cloth fell from his forehead to his lap, and he stared up at Katsuki with a crazed gaze that was veiled by the blurriness of fever, looking and sounding too fucking delirious for Katsuki’s liking. “Kacchan, you need to take it. You – You g-gotta take it”.

“Take what, asshole?”

“Take it. Please, you have to. Y-You have to –”

“Deku -”

“Take it, Kacchan. B-Before – Before I –”

“Stop that!”, he pushed Deku back on the bed, loosening the boy’s weak grasp on his shirt and tucking his hands into his covers. He shoved away the streak of hair that Deku was trying to shove into his mouth and snarled angrily at him.

He was so angry. No one could make him feel as angry as Deku did.

Apparently, no one could make him as scared, either. What a pathetic turn of fucking events.

“I’m dying”, Izuku sobbed miserably, wriggling beneath the covers and squeezing his eyes shut. He looked like he had maggots crawling on his skin, like he was trying to get rid of them. He kept twisting and moving on the bed, uselessly attempting to free his arms from the covers in which Katsuki had tucked them. His fever was skyrocketing. “I’m sorry mom. I c-couldn’t do it. I’m sorry. I’m dying. I’m d-dying. All Might. I’m – I’m dying. Please, tell them… T-Tell Kacchan, T-Todoroki, please, why are they b-burning me, I’m – I’m –“

“Deku, quit that crap”, Katsuki grabbed his shoulders. “You’re not dying. Do you hear me?”

“Kacchan”, Izuku sobbed. “K-Kacchan. Kacchan”.

“You’re not dying. Do you think I’d ever let you fucking die? Before I can kick your ass and become number one? You really think I’d let that happen?”

“K-Kacchan”.

“Didn’t you say you were going to get better and beat me? Are you fucking backing down on me?”

Izuku stared at him with confused eyes.

“Y-You – You gotta take it. Please”, was what he said after a few seconds of silence. His voice was small and croaked, slurred from fever and a month-long coma.

Katsuki lowered his head in fury and defeat, taking a deep breath before glaring at Izuku.

“I’ve already taken it. Ok?”, he spat, furious. “It's fine. I took it. Stop fucking worrying about it”.

“Y-You took it?”, Izuku asked with wide, wet, confused eyes.

“Yeah, I fucking took it. Is that what you fucking wanted? I took it. It's with me, now. It's safe”.

Izuku blinked up with a glassy gaze at him.

As Katsuki’s words sunk in, he sighed in relief, the trace of a smile blossoming in his chapped lips. The shoulders Katsuki was holding relaxed, and Izuku allowed himself to sink back into the bed.

“T-Thank you, Kacchan”.

And then Izuku passed out, his head lolling limply to the side.

Katsuki sighed and let go of the boy’s shoulders, taking a moment to catch a deep breath before he placed the damp cloth back on Deku’s forehead.

“Do you need me to get Kirishima for you?”

He didn’t reply, head between his knees and nausea making his stomach twist and turn.

“Bakugou. If you don’t answer, I will take it as a yes”.

He breathed in, breathed out. Tried his best to swallow past the sickness. He couldn’t throw up, otherwise Deku’s quirk would be expelled out of his organism, and he needed to take care of it, he needed to look after it –

“Yes, it’s me. I am in the men’s bathroom with Bakugou. He needs you. Physically, yes. I’m not sure he can hear me. Ok”.

Todoroki crouched down beside him.

“Kirishima will be here soon. I will wait until he arrives”.

“Piss off”.

“So you can hear me. That’s good to know”.

“Fuck off, Icy Hot”.

“As much as I would like to, I can’t leave you alone right now. All Might’s orders”.

“Well, then why the fuck isn’t All Might here, then, huh?”, Katsuki raised his head to glare daggers at Todoroki, feeling – and probably looking – like a mess.

“He is probably going through the same as you. I don’t know what happened in that room after I left, but I assume it mustn’t have been pleasant”.

Katsuki felt anger course through his veins like magma. Fuck that last session of anger management and “think before you speak” crap. Fuck anger management in the first place.

"Yeah, shithead, I wouldn't exactly say that Deku fucking flatlining *can be considered pleasant, and that's coming from the guy who hated his guts for years".*

Todoroki stared at him in shock. It was a rare look to see at that ever-neutral face.

"He flatlined?", Todoroki asked, and Katsuki hated that tone in the boy's voice.

"Yeah, you half-and-half bastard, he fucking died*, and Recovery Girl had to reanimate him, and holy fucking shit, I need to fucking talk to All Might –"*

"Bakugou", Todoroki stopped him from getting up by holding both Katsuki's forearms. He sounded serious but concerned, calm but worried. Katsuki didn't like it. He was too fucking cold. "You can't talk to All Might right now".

"Get the fuck off me".

"He explicitly told me not to –"

"Get the fuck off me!"

He didn't mean to set off the explosion, but it did happen anyway. Todoroki was thrown back and collided painfully against the bathroom wall, whereas Katsuki's ear exploded in a universe of sharp pain and loud feedback. He yanked the hearing aid off his ear and flinched, clutching his head between his hands and hissing.

He was on his knees on the floor, pain blinding his vision and dulling his senses. He couldn't tell if there was someone talking to him or even touching him – all he could register was the constant, high-pitched, ringing sound in his ears that was exactly like the sound Deku's heart monitor made when his heart stopped.

He opened his eyes and saw Kirishima's worried face coming in and out of focus in front of him. When had he arrived? His mouth was opening and closing as it formed words, but Katsuki couldn't hear them, couldn't make sense of what his friend was saying. He kept clutching his head, angry and confused and miserable at the same time because this was probably the worst day in his life by far and he couldn't even understand why.

He couldn't understand why. Deku was alive and he would (probably) be ok. Why did he still feel so fucking miserable? Why couldn't he fucking go back to feeling contempt for him?

Kirishima helped him to his feet and he immediately lost balance, which resulted on Todoroki helping the red-haired boy hold Katsuki up. Kirishima ran the sink and splashed a handful of cold water on Katsuki's face at the same time Todoroki placed a cool hand – his right one – at the back of his neck. It took a few minutes for Katsuki to snap out of his disoriented state, but his ear was still ringing, and once he looked stable enough, Kirishima helped him back to his room with Todoroki's aid.

“So can you fucking do it or what?

The girl looked at him with a distracted face, as if she was only half-listening to him. Katsuki couldn’t blame her for that, even if he would have preferred to have her whole attention – from the state of her working desk, she had a lot of tasks at hands.

“Oh, this? Yeah, sure, sure, I can do it. It’s child’s play, really, it will be ready by, uh, next week? No, scratch that, I have to figure out how to make a quirk-appropriate sensor, but that shouldn’t take long, so I’d say next week?”

Katsuki squinted his eyes at her.

“You just said to scratch next week”.

“Oh! Right. Ok, let me think”, Hatsume put down the equipment she was holding as she talked to Katsuki and turned to face him, giving him her whole attention for once. She studied him for a few moments before saying: “This baby shouldn’t be too hard to make with the tech we have today, but I need to be careful not to end up making the feedback even worse. Two weeks?”

“Fine”, Katsuki nodded grumpily at her, turning on his heels and ready to walk away.

“But do try and come here on the next week, it might be ready by then!”, she shouted at his back.

He didn’t respond as he exited the workshop.

“Kacchan…”

He stared at the silhouette, hand stretched towards him, as eight shadows stood behind it. The sight was ominous, but the voice was familiar, and it was calling out to him, and Katsuki stretched his hand, meaning to grab it, even though he didn’t know what would happen if he did…

And, just as he was about to touch the hand, he woke up.

He was panting and his eyes were wide as he jolted into awakening, brow covered in sweat and breath caught in his throat. He allowed his head to fall back against his pillow as he tried to regain his breathing before picking his phone to check the time.

3 a.m.

Oh, fucking great. Another restless night on the eve of a school day, on the top of all things.

He shoved the phone away, ignoring the notifications that told him he had unread messages, and turned on his side. He needed to catch some sleep. He needed to rest before his fucking classes.

Except he couldn't stop thinking about the fact that this was the third or fourth time he had the exact same fucking dream, and that it always ended the same way.

After he spent almost half an hour tossing and turning, Katsuki decided it was useless to keep trying to sleep. He would have to get up in an hour and a half, anyway. Might as well put that time into use.

He dressed up in his work-out clothes and walked out of the room, leaving his phone behind. He needed to be on the top of his game. He needed to train and give his best if he still planned on *ever* becoming a pro hero, after everything that had happened.

The last person he expected to find at the gym at 3 a.m. of a fucking Monday was Icy Hot, though, but Katsuki was aware, deep down, that he shouldn't be exactly fucking surprised by that. He was starting to learn that even if Todoroki was cold (no pun intended), he had a soft spot for Deku. He was probably losing sleep over him just as much as Katsuki was, not that he would ever admit that Deku was the reason for his insomnia.

He shouldn't be. Deku would be fine. He was alive. Acting like this was fucking stupid and it made no sense, which, frankly, only served to increase Katsuki's already dormant anger. He hated things that didn't make sense.

Todoroki simply stared at him with a neutral, unsurprised face as Katsuki entered the room, stopping what he was doing for a split second before going back to his silent training.

Katsuki walked as far away as he possibly could from Todoroki and started to stretch before he could get to the actual training, not even looking at the boy's general direction. He hadn't bothered to put his hearing aid on, since he didn't expect to meet anyone on his late – or rather early – training session, so if Todoroki actually spoke to him for whatever goddamned reason, the chances Katsuki wouldn't actually be able to hear him from that distance were very high.

He finished stretching up and got to the floor in order to do some push-ups, then a series of bench presses with the weights UA provided the gym, then a series of abdominal work.

He liked physical exertion. It helped him relieve stress. It was a cool outlet for his anger – if he was tired, he lacked the energy to have outbursts. It also had helped him keep in shape. That was why he enjoyed sparring with Kirishima so much – it killed two birds with one stone, with the bonus feature of helping Kirishima improve his fighting skills as well.

Now he would have to train alone, apparently. And that was Kirishima's fucking loss, not his. Katsuki's damn therapist said he needed to find other ways to let his anger out, so if fighting couldn't do, training it was. He didn't need Kirishima for shit. *For. Shit.* Kirishima was the one who fucking needed him, not the other way around.

(He tried his best to ignore the fact that the ache in his heart had only gotten worse ever since his not-really-a-fight with his best friend).

Asshole. Katsuki was still pissed off at him, even if he knew the boy meant well.

Yeah. Kirishima meant well. His *intentions* were what mattered the most, right? At least they mattered more than the fact that he had fucking turned his back on Katsuki in a moment of crisis.

But he had to admit that everything was way quieter without Kirishima around to bugger him off. Not just because it was 3 a.m., but *also* because he had no sparring partner, which meant he had to practice his moves and kicks and punches all by himself, against thin air. And thin air tended not to tease him, and make comments, and run its mouth on him during the fights.

Thin air tended not to talk about shitty Deku when that was the last subject he wanted to talk about. Thin air tended not to care about him, and worry about him, and invite him over for lunch or for dinner as a way to prevent him from isolating himself. Thin air tended not to text him the most ridiculous, cringy shit at late nights just because it missed him.

And on the other hand… Thin air also tended not to call him "Kacchan", and to say *sugoi* with an annoying frequency, and to stare at him with big, expressive green eyes that were full of admiration and… and…

You are the person Midoriya shonen holds the most admiration, love, devotion, and reverence for.

Yeah. That word. The L word.

Fuck. He missed Kirishima. He missed Deku.

But he didn't want to admit either of those things. He didn't want to have to deal with the repercussion of that. Most of all, he didn't want to beg.

Because he was in the wrong, he knew he was in the wrong. He had been in the wrong for years, now, but what felt worse than being in the wrong was having to admit that. Even after everything that had happened, after everything he had gone through, he still couldn't bring himself to go over to Kirishima's bedroom and apologize for taking his anger out on him. There was this childish part of him that he couldn't quite get rid of, and that prevented him from throwing the towel and letting Kirishima win for once.

(He had managed to apologize to Deku after over a decade of abuse, but the only reason that had happened was because he nearly lost the boy forever).

(He didn't want to lose Kirishima, too).

Internalizing this type of feeling is not good for you, he could almost hear his therapist tell him. But fuck her. She didn't even know Deku. She didn't know Kirishima. She didn't know shit about them, so she didn't have a say on what Katsuki could or couldn't internalize.

And what the fuck had All Might even fucking meant, anyway? Deku didn't fucking *love* him. He thought Katsuki was the shit, that was true, but he didn't love him. Couldn't love him. Why the fuck would he, anyway? Katsuki never gave him any fucking reason to.

And despite everything you did to me… I still love you, Kacchan. I always have.

Fuck that. Deku couldn't have meant that. Was he fucked in the head or something?

Did your mom drop you as a baby? Or were you born fucked up in the head? Because those are the only two explanations I have for you to look up to me like you insist you do, despite all the fucked-up shit I did to you.

You're my image of a hero. Not because of your flaws, but despite them.

Fuck that. Fuck that so much. Katsuki hated Deku for ever making him experience the shit he was experiencing in the first place.

Because before, things were simple. Anger and rage, and that was it. No twists in his chest. No butterflies in his stomach. No fucking impending sense of doom all the damn time.

No nightmares. No weird dreams. No feeling afraid about Deku dying in the middle of the night.

Because he *was* afraid. He never gave a single shit about Deku before, because he knew that, no matter what happened, he would always be there to piss him off. He would always be there to trail right after him, to yell his "*matte yo, Kacchan!*"s and his "*Kacchan, sugoi!*"s. And Katsuki had taken him for granted. He had trusted that Deku would always be there to piss him the fuck off, and he was wrong, because Deku was stuck in a hospital bed after spending a month without his soul and a month in a damn coma, and he was about to wake up and Katsuki didn't even know what to fucking tell him. "Yo, asshole, thanks for taking the blow for me"? That didn't feel right. Not after everything they had gone through.

Because the month they spent together changed them. It changed the way they saw each other, the way they talked to each other, the way they felt for one another. Katsuki didn't hate Deku's guts anymore. If anything, he even sort of liked Deku now, which was an alien fucking concept he hadn't gotten used to yet. It still felt wrong, after all those years of misunderstandings and fights. It still felt wrong, even after he spent one month bound to Deku's soul.

Everything felt wrong. Deku being with him, and now Deku being away from him. Deku being in a hospital bed. Deku passing his quirk to him, *trusting* his quirk to him. Deku acting like Katsuki was fit to be All Might's heir in his place.

There was just no way to talk to him anymore. If Katsuki was as harsh as he used to be before the incident, Deku would be hurt (as Katsuki himself had experienced firsthand). If Katsuki gentle to him, he would feel weak – that was a notion he was still having trouble abandoning. There was no easy way out of this, really, and though Katsuki hated having things easy, he also hated feeling as lost and confused as he had been feeling for the past weeks.

He wished he could catch a break. Just one break from everything, just so that he could put his thoughts in order and figure out exactly what Deku meant to him. Childhood friend? Rival? Frenemy? *Friend*? He had no fucking idea. He had no fucking idea what Deku meant to him, and thus he had no idea how to fucking act around him. And none of his current problems pissed him the fuck off more than that one, especially now he knew Deku was about to wake up after a whole month.

He didn't even realize Todoroki had approached him on the training mat, since he didn't have his hearing aid on, until the boy blocked one of Katsuki's kicks midair using his forearm. If he hadn't blocked it, Katsuki would have probably given him a pretty concussion, since he had no reason to hold back against thin air.

He glared at Todoroki, whose arm was still raised defensively beside his head. Slowly, and not breaking eye contact, Katsuki put his leg down, which resulted on Todoroki lowering the arm he had used as a shield.

Todoroki stayed where he was, staring at Katsuki with a mysterious look on his face. The expression looked almost inviting.

Katsuki took a few steps back and turned his back to the boy, going back to sparring against thin air a few feet away.

Todoroki walked closer to him again and blocked another one of his blows, this time holding Katsuki's fist mid-punch.

Katsuki stared at him.

Todoroki stared back.

He freed himself from Todoroki's grasp and took a couple of steps back. Todoroki stood his ground, silent. Cold.

Katsuki aimed a kick at Todoroki's midsection. Todoroki blocked it.

Katsuki regained his balance and aimed a punch at Todoroki's face. Todoroki dodged it.

Katsuki aimed another punch at Todoroki's face, expecting the boy to dodge it again. Once he did exactly that, Katsuki used the shift in weight to crouch down and swipe Todoroki's feet

off the mat. Todoroki lost balance and fell on his butt.

Katsuki smirked at him, triumphant. Todoroki's eyes lit up with the challenge.

They began to spare silently, methodically, only the sounds of their breaths and an occasional grunt of effort breaking the quiet. Neither of them was counting points aloud, like Katsuki was used to doing with Kirishima, but they were both doing so in their heads. When they reached the stage where they were both too tired and sweaty to keep going, it was a tie – seven wins for Katsuki and seven wins for Todoroki.

Todoroki sat on the mat, breathing heavily and sweating, as Katsuki walked over to the corner and grabbed themselves two bottles of water. Todoroki cooled his one down using his quirk before opening it and taking a sip.

"Couldn't sleep?", he asked Katsuki, who was drinking from his own bottle. The water wasn't as cool as he enjoyed it, but he would be damned if he asked the half-and-half bastard for any favors.

"Decided to do some early training", Katsuki provided, neither confirming nor denying Todoroki's assumption. This was probably the most civil they've ever been to each other in a long time, and definitely the first time they were so after the soul-quirk incident.

"Hm", Todoroki nodded, setting his bottle down and staring straight ahead, pensive. He was silent for a while, before adding: "I couldn't sleep, either".

Katsuki scoffed. Why the fuck did this asshole assume he knew anything about him? He had tried to be polite to the bastard for fucking once, but he had almost forgotten how *hard* Todoroki made politeness become. Katsuki was about to offer him a snappy response that would eventually lead into an argument, but before he could, Todoroki added:

"How was the soba?"

Katsuki snorted, scowling at the sitting boy from where he was standing up.

"It fucking *sucked*".

"So you ate it".

He fumed.

"Yeah, only because I had a hunch that it would fucking suck and I wanted to prove myself right".

Todoroki half-sighed, half-breathed hard.

"I didn't expect anything less from frozen, market soba".

Katsuki stared at him, feeling his blood begin to boil from indignation.

"You didn't even cook it your fucking *self*?"

“I’m not exactly good at cooking”, Todoroki commented matter-of-factly, looking as neutral as ever. Katsuki, on the other hand, could feel himself right about to explode, a vein popping at his temple.

“Listen here, you fucking multicolored spicy popsicle –“

“Did you think about what Iida said?”

Katsuki squinted his eyes at him.

“*What*?”

Todoroki looked at him from where he was sitting cross-legged on the floor.

“Midoriya’s waking up today”.

Katsuki scoffed, trying his best to pretend that hearing the fucking name didn’t make him feel like he was getting punched in the gut, even after a month.

“I fucking *know* that”.

“And you haven’t visited him in a month. At least not since that day Recovery Girl put him under”.

“You keeping fucking track of what I do or something, you fucking stalker?”

“No. But I have visited him every day, and I didn’t see you there once”.

For some reason, that statement made Katsuki’s blood boil even hotter. What the fuck was it about Todoroki that made the asshole inevitably piss the hell out of him with just mere seconds of conversation? And why the fuck did he always try to turn everything into a piss contest on who gave a bigger fuck about Deku?

And why the fuck did this stir up Katsuki’s competitive side and made him want to fucking *win* the piss contest?

“Yeah. I didn’t visit because I was fucking *busy*. It’s not my fault you don’t have anything to do all fucking day long”, he snapped, a bit too defensive.

“Hm”, Todoroki hummed simply. Katsuki scoffed.

“What?”

“*What*?”

“The fuck you looking so judgmental about?”

Todoroki stared at him with a blank, neutral face.

“I’m not”.

“Don’t think you know shit about me and Deku just because you’ve been around him for a couple months. I’ve known the fucker my whole damn *life*”.

“And yet, you were never friends”.

Katsuki glared at Todoroki.

“Yeah. So I don’t really get why the fuck you all keep insisting that I should fucking go see him or whatever it is you want me to do. I happened to get stuck with him for a month. It doesn’t mean we’re best buddies, now”.

Todoroki stared at him in silence.

“But now you care about him”.

Katsuki scoffed and gave him a humorless, almost threatening smile.

“Listen here –“

“I was there with you”.

Silence. Katsuki’s glare was intense.

“Back when Midoriya’s soul was returned and he almost...”, he trailed off, averting his eyes from Katsuki. “I know what I saw”.

Katsuki snarled.

“You don’t know *shit*, Icy Hot”.

“This isn’t about *you*, Bakugou”.

“Oh, yeah? Then why the fuck do you keep coming to *me* and talking to *me* about this crap?”

“Because Midoriya needs you”.

A pause. Todoroki tilted his chin up so that he could stare at Katsuki.

“This is for him. You were the one who kept him company in his most fragile moment”.

“Because I didn’t have any fucking say in it”, he spat without missing a beat, more out of habit than out of honesty.

“It doesn’t change the fact that it was you. And that you know, better than anyone, what he went through”.

Katsuki stared at him, face twisted in a mixture of anger and hesitation. Todoroki stared back.

“I was there, too, during his fever. Before you arrived”, he announced. Katsuki tried his best to maintain a neutral face at that information. If he didn’t know any better, Katsuki would

have sworn Todoroki sounded almost melancholic. “And I know what I’m saying when I tell you that having you around him will be good for his recovery”.

Katsuki’s lips formed a thin, stern line. He glared at Todoroki without saying anything.

“And no one will judge you for going”, Todoroki added sternly after a few moments, looking away from Katsuki again.

“As if I’d give a *shit* if you did”, Katsuki scoffed.

“Well, no one will”, he repeated, grabbing his water bottle and getting to his feet. He crossed the distance between himself and Katsuki’s sitting form, staring at him with a stern expression that left no place for a discussion. “It’s about time you look past these childish assumptions you have. Midoriya’s health matters more than stupid comments people who don’t know any better might make”, he offered his hand to Katsuki.

Katsuki stared at the hand and did nothing.

Todoroki sighed in something akin to resignation, retrieving his hand.

“Nice fight”.

Katsuki scoffed, getting to his feet on his own.

“Yeah, whatever”.

They both walked towards the door of the gym side by side, though there was a considerable distance separating them as they went.

“You need to train your footwork”, Todoroki commented absentmindedly after a few moments of silence.

“I didn’t ask for your fucking opinion. And my footwork is fine enough”.

“My seven wins say otherwise”.

“Well, *my* fucking seven wins say you’re a dumb fucker who’s about to get smacked if you don’t shut your mouth”.

Todoroki nodded and, if Katsuki didn’t know better, he would have sworn he spotted the hint of a smile in Half’n’Half’s lips.

“Katsuki-kun?”

“Hi”.

“I… I wasn’t expecting you”.

“I know. I… should have let you know I was coming over. It’s ok if you…”, he hesitated, not looking her in the eyes.

A few moments passed.

“I can leave”.

He could feel her eyes on him.

“It’s ok. You can come in”.

He didn’t look at her as he walked into the apartment, hands shoved into his pockets and head bowed. She closed the door behind him and walked over to where he was standing in the middle of the living room.

“Why don’t you take a seat?”, she offered, gesturing at the couch. He did so, and she sat beside him from a respectful distance.

They were silent.

“I’m – I’m glad you are here, Katsuki-kun”, she settled for saying. “I was worried about you”.

He frowned, genuinely confused, and met her eyes for the first time ever since he arrived.

“I visited you at the infirmary, before you properly woke up”, Inko continued. “I don’t suppose you’ll remember that”.

“No”, Katsuki admitted. “But my dad told me about it”.

Inko nodded. She looked tired – but not as tired as on the last times Katsuki had visited.

“Oh, I’m glad that he did”, she said, offering him a tiny smile that made the crinkles in her eyes look more evident.

An awkward silence fell upon them.

“How… How are you?”, she asked. Katsuki glared at her, hating how much she reminded him of Deku. Stupid big eyes, stupid concern, stupid altruism. Her son was dying in a hospital bed because of him and she still cared about his wellbeing. Still asked about how he was doing.

“I’m fine”, he answered, a bit too sharply, his face a bit too glare-y.

“That’s good to hear”, she smiled at him again, nodding her head slightly. “I was worried about your ear”.

Katsuki looked away once more, his hands tightening into fists. Stupid inconvenience, too – add that to the list.

“My ear’s fine”.

“Do you wear a hearing aid now?”

Katsuki sighed, impatient and frustrated. He didn’t offer her an answer.

“I’m only asking because Recovery Girl said the damage you sustained was irreversible and that made me worry about –“

“Why aren’t you mad at me?”

Inko blinked up at him, confused. Katsuki turned his head in order to glare at her.

“I’m… sorry?”

“If it wasn’t for me –“, he trailed off with a harsh intake of breath. Before continuing, he shook his head. “I didn’t answer the phone. I didn’t tell you about what I would do. I just went and – basically handed your son over to the villain who had tried to kill him”.

Inko frowned, outstretching her hand across the couch in order to grab Katsuki’s.

“Katsuki-kun. Have you been blaming yourself?”

“Fuck, no”, Katsuki lied and removed his hand from her grasp, the physical contact becoming too much out of a sudden. “But I figured you would be angry at me anyway. Thought it would be better to ask”.

Inko studied his face for a few moments.

“Why are you really here, Katsuki-kun?”

Katsuki squinted his eyes at her.

“What?”

“Did you come all the way here to tell me you don’t blame yourself for what happened? Or was it to demand I be angry at you?”

Katsuki stared at her.

“Why are you really here?”

He lowered his eyes. Looked away. Took a series of deep breaths before mustering the guts to reply to her rightful question.

She deserved to know. At this point, there was only so much Katsuki could do.

"I promised Deku I would take care of you".

Inko was silent.

"If anything happened to him, I would take care of you. Make sure you were looking after yourself and all that. That's the promise I made him".

He tilted his chin up and stared at her. Her eyes were wet with tears.

"He'll be gone for a while, and I'm a man of my fucking word. So here I am".

Inko offered him a wobbly smile, which resulted on a few of her tears escaping her eyes.

"Of course my Izuku would ask you to do that", she sniffed, wiping a few of her tears away with her fingers. "Oh, of course".

"Yeah. And I should have come over sooner – I know that", he added, feeling awkward. "But I…", he trailed off, not sure of what he could use as an excuse. I was freaking the fuck out? I was trying to sort my own shit? I was scared shitless that you would rightfully blame me for your son's demise even though I never really cared about him until recently?

"I understand, dear", Inko provided before he could find the right words, and her everlasting kindness was driving him up the fucking walls. "It's been tough for everyone".

No, it hasn't*, but Katsuki knew better than to argue with her on this.*

"Yeah", he settled for saying instead, not meeting her eyes.

"Thank you for making that promise", Inko told him. "And for coming over".

Katsuki nodded at her, silent.

"Have you been visiting him?"

He sighed. Did she really have to fucking go there?

(Did everyone?)

"No".

She seemed taken aback.

"Oh".

A pause.

"Really?"

"Yeah".

“Why not?”

Katsuki looked at her.

“There’s no point. He’s in a coma”.

Inko bowed her head, slightly taken aback by the bluntness of his words. It was probably hard for her to hear that, even after a month. Making her upset or coming off as rude hadn’t been Katsuki’s intention, for once, which was why he ended up adding:

“I’ll go when he’s awake”.

The words of his therapist kept echoing in his mind: is it true? Is it helpful? Is it inspiring? Is it necessary? Is it kind? He was pretty sure she had taken that off a children’s book, but it had been actually helping him a bit, if he needed to be honest. And what he had just told Inko fit all those requirements.

“I’m glad”, Inko smiled at him. “My Izuku will love to see you when he wakes up”.

Katsuki didn’t know what to say to that, so he stayed silent.

“Oh! That reminds me –“, she said, suddenly standing up from her seat. “I found something, the other day, when I was cleaning Izuku’s room up. It gets all dusty, that room, so I still clean it up even if he’s living at UA now. He took everything important with him, so I’m assuming he doesn’t really need what’s left behind. Stay here”, she said, right before disappearing into the hall.

Katsuki sat there in silence, desperate to just bid his farewell and go back to his room at the UA dorm, where it was dark and cozy and blissfully quiet.

No green eyes around to drive him nuts.

Inko came back less than a minute later, a notebook in her hands.

“I… I think he would have liked you to see this. He’s always shy about his notes, but I think they’re genius. All Might thinks so, too. He always needs a little push to show them off, you know? But once he does, he never stops ranting about them. And they’re all so thoughtful, you know? All Might says he’s got a good eye for that sort of thing, quirk analysis and all that. So maybe they’ll be of use to you. Maybe he’s seen something you haven’t”, she handed the notebook to him.

It looked exactly like those hundreds of notebooks Deku walked around with, containing annotations on the heroes he met and admired.

It looked exactly like that notebook Katsuki had yanked off Deku’s hands an eternity ago and burned up.

The only difference was that there wasn’t a number on the cover – just a messy handwriting that said “Bakugou Katsuki”.

He immediately felt pissed off by that – having Deku call him anything other than that stupid, annoying nickname was unsettling on its own. But, in opening the notebook and quickly going through its pages, Inko's eyes carefully glued to him, Katsuki could tell that this was a well-thought, quasi-professional series of analysis on… Well, on him. Deku had probably been trying to be actually serious about it when he wrote it down, which meant no 'Kacchan'*s and no* 'sugoi*'s.*

He closed the notebook down after glancing at some of the pages. He didn't really have the time, will, or patience to go through all that on that moment.

Inko smiled at him. He didn't manage to smile back.

"I was going to give it to you next time I went visiting him", she justified, probably out of the need to offer an explanation, even though she didn't really have to.

"Thanks", was what Katsuki managed to say as a response. Hah. How about that, shitty Deku? I just thanked someone, just like you always fucking insisted I should do. On your fucking face.

"I hope you like it", Inko smiled. Katsuki nodded at her silently, holding the notebook in his hands.

An awkward silence fell upon them. Katsuki just sat there, holding the notebook and staring at the carpet, until the tension in the room became too thick for him to keep ignoring.

"How are you?", he settled for asking – after all, that was his primary goal in going there.

"Oh, don't worry about me", Inko waved a dismissing hand at him, and then immediately went back to nervously fiddling with the hem of her shirt. "I'm doing fine, I'm fine. I'm way better, now that I know my boy is… Well. Recovering".

Katsuki nodded at her.

"You look better".

"Thank you", she smiled softly.

"Are you, uh, eating properly and all that stuff?", he insisted, because he remembered all about Inko's reluctance to eat and take care of herself last time he visited and he had made shitty Deku a fucking promise, no matter how pathetic and ridiculous he felt saying those words of concern aloud.

Inko offered him a sincere, motherly smile and tilted her head to the side with affection.

"I'm ok, Katsuki-kun", she told him emphatically. "You don't have to worry about me, all right? I'm ok, now that I know my Izuku will be fine".

Katsuki nodded. She did look better, and he saw no reason to keep pushing the subject.

"And I have you to thank for that", she added, which made Katsuki frown.

She reached out and grabbed his hand once more. This time, he let her.

"You were the only one brave enough to try and do something", she told him. "While UA kept secrets about my own son from me, while All Might hid things from me… You were the only one who stood up for me and helped me figure out what was happening to my son. Actually – you were the only one who actually managed to do something for Izuku. You were the one who captured that villain. And, for that, I'll forever be grateful".

Katsuki stared at her, blinking blankly. There were several things he wanted to tell her, but his mind was blank.

"And yes, there are things that you've done to Izuku that I don't think I'll ever be able to forget, but if it will make you feel better, please, know that – for everything you did, for all the words you've said – you are forgiven".

Katsuki stared at her, angry. Midoriyas and their fucking forgiveness. He tried to snap his hand away from her hold in anger and annoyance, because he didn't ask for her forgiveness, but she tightened her grip, preventing him from doing so.

"And I am grateful", she concluded, clutching his hand and staring up at him with big moist eyes. "That you got to save my son. That you managed to bring my baby boy back to me".

She sniffed, wiping her rolling tears away. Katsuki just stared at her, face blank.

"That you proved you really are the hero he always knew you would become".

Katsuki didn't react when Inko surged forwards and enveloped him in a tight, heartfelt hug. He simply sat there, arms limp and on his sides, as Deku's mother squeezed him tightly and motherly in a way that felt wonderful and revolting at the same time.

"You don't have to do that", he ended up saying before his brain could catch up with his mouth, before he could really think about the words. "He can't feel it anymore".

Inko broke the hug just enough to be able to stare at Katsuki, her eyebrows scrunched in concern and confusion before her face fell in comprehension.

"I know he can't, dear", she told him with the saddest of smiles before pulling Katsuki back into another hug and holding him in her arms, tighter than before.

Katsuki didn't hug her back, but allowed himself to rest his head on her shoulder as she ran her fingers soothingly through his hair.

From: Shitty Hair

Hey, man. How are you?

From: Shitty Hair

You busy?

From: Shitty Hair

I understand if you're mad at me, but I didn't want to pick up a fight, man. I was just trying to help you, you know? Cause what you're doing isn't good for you

From: Shitty Hair

We can keep sparring if you want to. I just need you to understand that there are better ways to let your anger out you know

From: Shitty Hair

You at your room? Can I come over?

Missed call from: Shitty Hair

From: Shitty Hair

Well, anyway… Hit me up when u can ok? I don't want you to be mad at me or to isolate urself

From: Raccoon Eyes

Ok what's going on Kiri is all upset and he won't tell me why but I know it has to do with you because you haven't been around all day

From: Raccoon Eyes

Will you tell me what it is willingly or will I have to come over and tear the truth away from you?

From: Raccoon Eyes

I mean it tho. I hate seeing you both like this

Katsuki put his phone down and rolled his eyes, going back to his online sign language classes. He had better things to do with the remains of his weekend break than worry about Kirishima and Mina. Didn't they all keep insisting he needed to take care of himself? That was precisely what he was trying to fucking do.

Get better at sign language. Train hard. Work out. Keep in shape. Get back to the top. He would accomplish none of that if he kept thinking about Deku, if he kept letting himself be slowed down by the fucker.

God. Not thinking about Deku had never been an issue before. Why was it so fucking hard, now? What the fuck was happening to him?

He resumed the daily class and then focused on his actual homework, which he was supposed to hand in on the next morning. The questions were all easy and the essay on quirk theory he was supposed to compose came to him as easily as training, which meant he managed to finish everything in the span of two hours. That left him with a lot of free time and nothing to do.

He thought about calling All Might for another training session, but he knew exactly what the man's answer would be.

Where he would be.

Katsuki sighed, throwing his head back and groaning. He tried to figure out what he could have possibly done to make whatever deity ruled the world decide he needed to suffer like this.

He got up from his rolling chair and was about to force himself into another working out session when he spotted the notebook at the corner of his studying desk.

It was there, just where he had left it on that day when he came back from the visit to Inko. Unharmed. Untouched.

Unread.

He stared at the notebook for long moments as if it had personally offended him. As if the writing of his full name had offended him. As if the fact that Deku had taken so much time and effort had offended him. As if the fact that Deku had paid so much attention to him had offended him.

He ended up grabbing the notebook and sitting on his bed.

Just as he had imagined, the pages were filled with well-made observations regarding Katsuki's quirk and abilities. The notebook grew more accurate as the pages went on – the first ones mostly childish observations that tried and failed to sound accurate, whereas the notes from the middle on sounded more like suggestions and speculation.

Several of Deku's points hadn't even crossed Katsuki's mind before, which was unsettling and made him angry. To know that the asshole had thought more about Katsuki's quirk than Katsuki himself pissed him off to no end, but he couldn't really blame Deku – not having a quirk of his own, all he could do was observe others'.

Katsuki stopped himself, realizing that – that he hadn't… Well.

That he had just… empathized with Deku? Even though he wasn't even there anymore? Even though he had been feeling angry? He had just successfully managed to think about how Deku must have felt, what he must have thought, instead of downright feeling *angry* at him. And they weren't even soulbound anymore, so Katsuki couldn't blame it on that.

He stared at the notebook on his lap and suppressed the urge to throw it across the room.

He felt angry for not feeling angry, if that even made sense.

The rest of Deku's notes were crap, since Katsuki already knew all about that shit. "Quirk works better on close combat". "When used properly, quirk can propel him into quasi-flight". "Destructive if not used carefully". "Not recommended for combat in closed spaces". "More combative than rescue-appropriate". Tch.

However, even though he already knew about all the shit Deku had written down, Katsuki found he couldn't stop reading it. He found that he was hearing the words in Deku's voice inside his head, and he could almost picture the way the boy's brow must have scrunched up in concentration as he wrote those things down on his notebook. He could imagine Deku supporting his chin with one hand as he wrote non-stop with his other, the tip of his tongue sticking out past his lips as he registered note after note. And, if anything, the image and the voice and the notes themselves made Katsuki realize that, no matter how hard he pretended not to, no matter how much he tried to suppress it, no matter how often he lied to himself, he actually fucking *missed* Deku. He missed him like hell.

And he felt angry for missing the bastard, because he didn't want to – he never fucking *wanted* to. He never chose to be stuck with Deku for one month. He never chose to get used to the fucker's presence, to his constant rants, to his rambling, to his comments, to his questions, to the way he tilted his head to the side when he didn't understand something, to the way he stared at Katsuki with those big, expressive eyes, to the way he twitched and moved in his sleep, to the way he scrubbed his eyes lazily when he woke up, to the way he looked like a harmless puppy whenever he was sharing Katsuki's anger, to the way he looked determined whenever they had an argument, to the way he smelled, to the way he looked, to the way he talked, to the way he laughed, to the way his green hair had looked when it was hit by the golden streaks of the sun in that last day before Katsuki lost him.

Katsuki felt angry, and he felt confused, because he was supposed to *hate* Deku, that was his fucking modus operandi, but he didn't hate him anymore and instead felt something else. Something he couldn't name or even entirely comprehend, something he couldn't make sense of, but that made his heart hurt and his chest feel tight. It made him want to punch and punch and *punch* things until that feeling went away, because violence and screaming were the only ways he had ever been taught to deal with his emotions.

He didn't want to be violent to Deku anymore, and that realization hit him like a truck, leaving him breathless and shocked as he stared at the notebook with tightly sealed lips.

Surely, he still wanted to be better than the bastard; he still wanted to be the number one hero, because that was an ambition that had never faltered in his life and that probably never would. But all he could think about was the way he had shouted at Deku while the boy lied in bed hallucinating with fever, and how utterly miserable he had looked after Katsuki's aggression. Usually, Deku sucked it up, but while dealing with a fever, while dealing with the sheer weakness of his body, all his walls had been down and he had been stripped bare before Katsuki, in his most vulnerable state.

That was how Deku always felt whenever Katsuki was mean to him. Sad, and confused, and teary. Katsuki didn't have to see him vulnerable and burning up with fever to know that – he had felt it first hand, in all those times he had hurt Deku while their souls were bound.

And yeah, maybe it would feel alien and weak and pathetic if he tried to control his anger better when he was around the boy, but after everything they had gone through together, he decided he could make that small sacrifice, if it would only mean Deku wouldn't be so hurt anymore. He had already put Deku through enough pain, right? Not only during all the years they'd known each other, but also… But also during those past months.

Katsuki didn't want to see him any more hurt. At least not because of him.

And, on the other hand, that was what his fucking anger management therapy was all about, right? Finding a way to stop him from being so mean to people all the fucking time.

He ended up falling asleep half-way through reading Deku's notebook, feeling some level of relief after finally figuring out one of the many issues that had been troubling his mind recently.

When Katsuki showed up, Deku had been awake for a day.

He woke up in the middle of the Monday afternoon, hours after Recovery Girl took him off sedation. Katsuki didn't know how it went, or even asked anyone about it. He hadn't replied to Kirishima's texts or commented on the looks Todoroki kept sending him throughout the Monday class. All he did know, because Kirishima wouldn't stop fucking texting him despite his lack of response, was that Deku was awake, but still confused and tired.

But of course every single one of those fuckers would think about visiting Deku right after he woke up, since they had no fucking common sense at all. Which meant Deku's room would

be full of people, and that Deku himself would probably be more tired and disoriented than anything. Those were the factors that made Katsuki opt for a Tuesday visit.

Well. A late-night Tuesday visit. He only hoped all the eager fuckers who wanted to see Deku had visited already by then.

It was way past curfew when Katsuki arrived at Recovery Girl's medical bay, and the place was blissfully empty. Katsuki didn't know if putting on the special clothes before entering Deku's room was still a necessity – after all, he hadn't visited in a month and had no idea how Deku's immune system was doing these days, so he figured it would be better to go looking for Recovery Girl before he could barge into Deku's room bearing any potential germs.

"Ah, Bakugou", she raised an eyebrow at him when she spotted him standing at the entrance of her office. "You took your time. You're here to see Midoriya, I presume?"

"What do you think?", he ended up blurting out despite himself. Recovery Girl made a face at him.

"You're still leaving your manners in your room before you walk out, I can see", she commented, hopping off her chair and making her way over to him in order to lead him to Deku's room. "His mother just left, since she has to work first thing in the morning. All Might should be arriving any time soon, and I already kicked out the other friends who came to visit. I assumed you would want some alone time with him".

Katsuki didn't nod or offer a response, not sure he wanted to confirm Recovery Girl's assumption, even though it was the truth.

"I should let you know that he has just woken up from a month-long coma. Well – a two-month-long coma, if you count the time he lied around without his soul. You shouldn't expect him to be too coherent or lively. He still has a long path of recovery ahead of him before he can even think about leaving this bay", she told him as they arrived at the door to the room. "He hasn't been speaking much, either. It will take him a while to do so properly, and he'll need a lot of speech therapy, as well as physiotherapy when he's up to it".

"Right", Katsuki commented.

"Don't overwork him. If he wants to sleep, let him. He needs all the rest he can get", she warned, giving Katsuki a stern look.

"I ain't about to start a fucking work out session with him in there", Katsuki retorted.

"You know what I mean, young man", she slammed her cane down on his foot, earning a hiss and a growl out of him. She pointed a warning finger at his face. "No. Arguments".

Katsuki rolled his eyes and sighed.

"I know".

“And no discussions, either! Nothing that gets him too worked up, or I’ll kick you out permanently. Do you understand?”, she raised an eyebrow at him and squinted her tiny eyes as she waited for confirmation.

“*Fine*”, Katsuki grunted.

“Good. Now clean your hands up and put that mask on”, Recovery Girl nodded at him. “After that, you can go in”.

Katsuki cleaned his hands up with alcohol and put on a mask that covered his nose and his mouth before turning back towards Recovery Girl. She nodded her approval at him and then opened the door to the room.

“In you go, boy. I’ll come fetch you in a while”.

Katsuki nodded at her, and then stepped into the room.

Not much was different from the last time he visited – Deku was still bony, still lying in bed, still hooked up to a lot of wires. The steady beating of his heart echoed soundly across the room and he seemed asleep. Katsuki approached him.

Deku’s eyes were closed and still sunken on his pale face, his lips white and chapped and his hair a dull green against his forehead. He looked peaceful, but still too thin – if it weren’t for the covers on the top of his torso, Katsuki was sure he would have been able to see his ribs sticking out.

His hair was still a mess of full curls that were too big for his bony head, and Katsuki vaguely wondered if Deku would still be up to letting him give him a haircut. Since he seemed to be fast asleep, Katsuki idly shoved away some of the curls that had fallen atop of his eyes while he slept, revealing a galaxy of freckles that stood out more than ever across his pale cheeks. Then, he reached down and grabbed Deku’s wrist, his fingertips searching for a pulse beneath that skin even if he could perfectly hear the sound of the heart monitor echoing in the silence of the room.

Deku’s eyes began to roll beneath their eyelids and Katsuki quickly withdrew his hand, staring down at the boy in anticipation as he blinked his lazy eyes open and looked around with a glassy gaze. Eventually, his green eyes found Katsuki and took longer than they should have to recognize him.

“Hey, dipshit”, Katsuki greeted, going out of his way to sound neutral.

It was hard. To sound neutral, that is. Because this – this was too much. It had been two whole months ever since he saw Deku awake – actual Deku, physical Deku. It had been one entire month ever since he had Deku’s eyes locking with his. And as much as Katsuki was the farthest possible from an emotional person, he couldn’t deny that he was feeling an extreme sense of relief upon seeing Deku like this – alive, and awake, and not delusional with fever. Because those were the last stances he had seen of the boy until now – flatlining on that hospital bed because of his quirk, and burning up with fever before Recovery Girl put him under.

Now Deku was awake. And staring at him. And his mouth was opening and closing as if he had forgotten how to speak.

“K… Ka…”, he attempted, but it was fruitless.

“Yeah, I know what my name is, you don’t have to try so fucking hard. How’re you holding up?”

Izuku frowned, looking like it was taking him a while to catch up with what Katsuki said to him. He blinked sluggishly, confused, before opening his mouth again.

“Uh… I… Uh…”, he stuttered, sounding like he couldn’t remember how to articulate words. Katsuki stood beside his bed, watching with attention, but he couldn’t deny that all the hesitation and the lack of words were making him impatient. He had never fucking thought that he would actually come to miss Deku’s fast-paced rambles.

“Just nod yes or no, dumbass. You’re in no condition to speak yet”, Katsuki interrupted Deku’s constant grumbling. Upon Deku’s confused and frustrated look, Katsuki rolled his eyes, realizing there was no possible way the boy could answer his question with ‘yes’ or ‘no’. he sighed. “Fine. Are you ok? Yes or no?”

Deku blinked at him for a few moments before nodding sluggishly.

“Good. That’s what I wanted to know”, Katsuki said, turning on his heels. Before he could walk away, Deku’s limp hand grasped the hem of his shirt, trying to hold him in place. Katsuki looked at him. “I wasn’t actually leaving, you idiot. I’m just gonna grab that chair”, he nodded at the chair which was sitting at the farthest corner of the room.

Deku actually blushed at this, which made his face look a bit healthier, if anything. Katsuki grabbed the chair and placed it right beside Deku’s bed, sitting down at his eyelevel.

“So, you’re still trying to figure out how the fuck to speak right? Who knew it would take a fucking coma to finally make you shut up?”, he commented, but as soon as the words, which were a weak attempt to mimic their usual banter, came out of his mouth, they felt wrong. Deku wasn’t laughing, and in fact looked more confused than anything, which was only expectable.

Katsuki sighed, feeling awkward. He bowed his head.

“You’ll probably go back to your rants soon enough, so don’t break a sweat”, he added in a weak attempt to comfort him. When he finally faced Deku, the boy was frowning harder than ever.

He pointed a weak finger at Katsuki, unable to voice his question. Katsuki stared at the finger, and then at Deku.

“What?”, he asked.

Deku pointed at him again, and seemed to mouth the word “ok”.

“You want to know if I’m ok?”, Katsuki scoffed in disbelief.

Deku nodded weakly, a worried expression taking over his face.

“You’re such a little fucker”, Katsuki replied angrily, scoffing again and shaking his head in disapproval. What the ever-loving fuck was wrong with Deku?

Deku’s frown deepened.

“Yeah, I’m *ok*, Deku”, Katsuki said harshly. “In case you haven’t noticed, *you’re* the one who’s looking like shit and lying on a hospital bed, so can you stop being such a *dumbass* for once in your life and worry about yourself for a fucking change?”

Deku blinked up at him, mouth opening and closing but no sound coming out. He looked miserable and confused, but most of all frustrated for not being able to voice his thoughts.

“Fuck. Ok”, Katsuki lowered his head and raised it again, feeling ridiculously angry but trying his best to channel it in a way a way that didn’t end up blowing up at Deku’s face. “True. Helpful. Inspiring. Necessary. Kind”, he sighed. “Yes, Deku, I am *fine*. You don’t have to worry about me and you should focus on your own recovery. There. Are you fucking satisfied, now?”, he added.

Izuku stared at him with wide, disoriented eyes as if he had no idea what was happening.

“Ugh”, Katsuki grunted in frustration and threw his head back, slumping on his seat. “How long have you been awake anyway? Why the fuck can’t you speak?”

Izuku shrugged at him, looking helpless.

“W-W-W… W-W… W-Why…?”, he mustered, but his voice sounded hoarse and weak, almost too small to be heard, even in the silence of the room. It didn’t sound like Deku at all, but at the same time, it couldn’t be anybody else.

“Why what?”, Katsuki asked him with a grumpy look. “I don’t know why you can’t speak either, but it’s pissing me off”.

Izuku shook his head no and pointed at him. Katsuki glared at the boy’s finger.

“Why I’m what?”, Katsuki urged. Izuku gestured weakly at the room around them and Katsuki squinted his eyes at him, suspicion and anger etched all over them. “You want to know why I’m *here*?”

Izuku nodded, looking confused and almost apologetic.

Katsuki gritted his teeth.

“Fuck, Deku, do you even remember anything about what happened?”, Katsuki scoffed.

Izuku nodded yes.

Katsuki felt angry. Where the fuck was the asshole trying to get, then?

“Then you *know* why the fuck I’m here”.

Izuku bowed his head, still looking apologetic.

“Don’t give me that fucking look. You’ve got nothing to be sorry for”.

Izuku stared at him with the saddest eyes in the world and took a trembling hand to his own ear. Katsuki did the same to his ear, his fingertips finding his hearing aid.

Katsuki allowed his hand to drop and gave Izuku a no-shit look before rolling his eyes.

“This wasn’t *you*; stop thinking so much of yourself. If anything, it was bound to happen sooner or later”, he grunted with annoyance.

Izuku kept watching him in silence with wide eyes that soon began to droop. He looked like he was forcing himself to stay awake, which was just like him, frankly. Katsuki sighed and stood up from the chair.

“You feeling cold?”, he asked Izuku, a bit more abruptly than he intended.

Izuku shook his head no, a slightly surprised look on his face.

“Hot?”

He shook his head no again.

“You need anything?”

He shook his head no.

“Good. I’m gonna get going, now, ‘cause we have class early tomorrow and I’m not gonna be late because of your ass”, Katsuki announced, shoving his hand into his pocket and searching for something.

He triumphantly fished out the small All Might keychain he had bought for Deku back when they went to the mall to get Kirishima his birthday present. He placed the keychain on Deku’s palm, and the boy stared at the object with even more confusion than before looking up at Katsuki with those stupid eyes of him.

“Don’t give me that fucking look”, Katsuki said, sounding almost aggressive. “I got it that day we went buying Kirishima’s present. Told myself I would only give it to you once you were back in your shitty body, so there it is”.

Deku stared at the keychain as if it was made of gold before staring up at Katsuki with wide eyes again.

“Now stop forcing yourself to stay awake and go back to sleep, dumbass. You’re helping no one by not resting”, he added, ruffling Deku’s hair a bit more harshly than necessary and

pushing his head against the pillow as a silent instruction for him to stay down before turning on his heels.

“K-K-Ka… K-Kaa–“, Izuku tried to call weakly as Katsuki walked away from the bed.

“Yeah, yeah, yeah”, Katsuki interrupted the stutters over his shoulder. “Go to sleep, Deku. I’m not telling you again”.

Izuku watched with confusion as Katsuki walked away from him and out of the room, still holding the All Might keychain in his weak grasp.

And as Katsuki walked away from the infirmary and towards the dorm building, he tried his best to calm down his racing heart.

Everything was a bit of a blur.

He remembered Recovery Girl telling him something. All Might asking questions. His mom, sobbing and crying and holding him close to her chest.

He remembered the villain, and jumping in front of Kacchan in order to protect him. After that, everything was dark and cold until he woke up in this hospital room.

There had been Uraraka, eyes red and wet, and Iida, looking relieved and emotional. Even Todoroki had gone as far as smiling at him, squeezing his shoulder and telling him something… Something he couldn’t really remember.

He couldn’t remember much more than that, if he was being honest.

Whenever he tried to speak, his tongue failed him. It felt heavy and thick in his mouth, like cotton coated in water, and he couldn’t go much farther than emitting a few sounds at the time. He hated it, if he was being honest – speaking was something that comforted him when he was feeling anxious, that allowed him to let out the steam and cope with stress.

Now, all he could do was grunt and moan. It was unsettling.

He was still a bit confused as to what was wrong with him. He felt weak, tired, and a bit hollow inside. Moving around was difficult and even sitting up was impossible; all he could manage to do was to move his hands a bit and even that left him exhausted afterwards. He couldn’t really remember Recovery Girl’s explanation for that, even if he was almost sure she had offered him one.

But the most remarkable visit of all had been Kacchan's; that was for certain. That left Izuku completely baffled and taken aback, more confused than he had ever felt before, even prior to the villain attack.

Kacchan had never acted like that towards him. He had never been gentle to Izuku before.

(Surely, Kacchan's definition of gentleness included name-calling and harsh remarks, but still – Izuku had known the guy for over a decade. He knew when Kacchan was being hostile and when he was being nice).

(Which, quite honestly, was a lot rarer than the former).

And Kacchan was being nice to him.

He had even given him a gift.

Which sort of freaked Izuku out.

He didn't know what had happened for Uraraka to cry, Iida to be emotional, Todoroki to smile, and Kacchan to be nice, but he figured it must have been something really, really important, even if he couldn't remember Recovery Girl's explanation. Maybe he could ask her about it later… When he woke up after he took a nap… Because he was feeling so tired…

Izuku drifted off into sleep peacefully, ignoring the empty feeling in his bones and still clutching the All Might keychain Kacchan had given him in his hand.

Chapter End Notes

Wowie. This one took forever, didn't it?
Sorry. Had a lot going on. New Avengers movie. Crazy stuff at work. Several protests because the political situation over here is nuts. But it's finally here!
This feels, to me, more like a transitionary chapter than anything else (hence the title). Those are needed every now and then. I do hope it's still enjoyable, though.
I was originally going to have the soba conversation take place between Bakugou and Todoroki, but it didn't feel right as I wrote it down. Trying to make Todoroki give Bakugou food after so many shaky confrontations... Ugh. I felt like they would have a "we-need-to-fight-in-order-to-understand-each-other" vibe like Bakudeku, so I settled for that instead. But that's just me. Also, I love Iida and I felt like he wasn't being featured enough in this.
Anyway. Bakubaby is an oblivious fool when it comes to the needs of the heart, but thankfully, his friends are not. Bless them for being so insistent.

Chapter 17: kernel panic

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"How fucking hard can it be for you just to copy what I'm doing?"

Izuku frowned in concentration, the tip of his tongue slipping subtly past his lips, trying again to mimic Katsuki. His gestures were too shaky and rusty to mean anything, though, and Katsuki sighed heavily and rolled his eyes. He reached out and grabbed one of Izuku's hands a bit more aggressively than he had intended to, stopping him mid-sign.

"Like *this*", he placed Deku's fingers in a proper position and adjusted his hand. "You hold these two fingers up with your thumb like this, then you wave your hand up to your forehead with the palm facing out", he forced Deku's hand into doing the gesture he had just described, and then he did it himself one more time in demonstration. "Go on. It's not that fucking hard".

Izuku stared at Katsuki's hand with attention, nodded solemnly and tightened his lips in concentration. Katsuki let go of him and Izuku attempted again.

Same result. Too shaky, rusty, and vague. And he was doing it in a way that probably meant another thing altogether, but Katsuki hadn't learned enough to be sure (not that he'd let Deku know that).

"Holy fucking *shit*, Deku", Katsuki grunted in annoyance, slumping back against his chair and staring at the ceiling as if he was begging some unknown deity for the patience he lacked. Izuku lowered his head in frustration and embarrassment before rubbing a closed fist with his thumb up against his chest in a circular motion.

Katsuki sighed, rolling his eyes again. The fucker was *apologizing*.

"Yeah, whatever. Let's try something else", Katsuki said simply in response, shifting positions on his chair so that Deku could watch him properly.

Since it would take a while until Deku was allowed to start speech therapy – or any sort of therapy, really –, Katsuki decided to ~~(try to)~~ teach the little asshole a bit of sign language, because Deku could barely even produce coherent words and not being able to communicate was obviously driving the boy crazy. For someone who was used to ranting and mumbling his thoughts to himself, having his tongue turned into lead was probably something akin to torture. Katsuki was, of course, still in the process of learning sign language as well, but he was already one month ahead of Deku and thus could show him the basics, at least.

There was no downside to this, after all – not only would Deku find a way to communicate with him without mumbling and stuttering and groaning uselessly like the idiot he was, which was what he had been doing so far, but he would also find something to busy his idle

mind with, since lying in bed all day with his mouth shut and doing nothing was bound to make him bored as *fuck*.

(Katsuki willingly chose to ignore the third reason why he was doing it, which was getting to be around the nerd and making sure he was still alive and breathing, but no one needed to know about that).

But Deku had woken up barely a week prior, and his brain was still slower and weaker than Katsuki was used to. He shouldn't have expected anything different, since having his body out of commission for two months was bound to do that to a person, but it still made Katsuki's skin itch, to see Deku like that – staring off at the distance with glassy eyes, opening and closing his mouth without producing any sound, looking like a shell of himself. He was in constant need of help to do basic things – eat, drink, and even turn on his side on the bed. He still slept for more hours than he stayed awake, and, sometimes, he still stared at people with that confused gaze, as if he had no idea what was happening or why he was there. And though Katsuki *knew* that was to be expected, since the nerd spent one month with no soul and then one month in a fucking coma, he couldn't say that the disorientation in Deku's eyes didn't drive him up the fucking walls. *Just get fucking better already, you wimp*.

Yeah. That's what Katsuki wanted to tell him, and the way he mostly felt about this situation. *I can't fucking stand seeing you like this. Just recover already, just get better already, you fucker.*

I can't stand seeing you like this.

And what made him angrier than anything was that he didn't understand, not really. Katsuki had no fucking clue why seeing Deku as a slim, bony, weak little bastard pissed him off so much, why he wanted to go back to muscular Deku, strong Deku, the Deku who could stand up to him and who defied him even after all those years of bullying and abuse. And, staring at the boy's pale, bony face, with green eyes sunken and shady, with that sick, unhealthy appearance, it suddenly dawned on him –

If you want to be a hero that badly, there's a quick way to do it. Just pray that you'll be born with a quirk on your next life and take a swan dive off the roof of the building.

Oh.

Right, yeah. That added up.

Because, no matter how hard of a time Katsuki had in denying all this shit, there was no way out of admitting that his relationship with Deku had changed over the course of two months. In fact, his relationship with Deku had done nothing other than *change* for all the time they've known each other – from best friends to acquaintances, from acquaintances to enemies, from enemies to rivals, and now from rivals to…

Well. Something like friends, more or less. Not in the same way Katsuki was friends with Kirishima or the other band of fuckers that liked to trail after him. In a different way.

But yeah.

And now, seeing Deku go all the way back to looking like that weak, pathetic little fucker he used to be back when Katsuki still bothered actually bullying him was fucking *disturbing*. Because… Because it made him feel bad.

If Deku used to look like that before All Might, before his quirk, before they got into UA… If he used to look like fucking *that*, then did that mean he used to be just unhealthy as he was now, as he lied on this hospital bed?

Did that mean Katsuki's abuse had *that* result on him?

And surely, Deku looked unhealthier now after two months of hell than he used to look back before UA, but this didn't mean the ridiculously close resemblance didn't bother the fuck out of Katsuki. And, out of a sudden, he could no longer look at Deku – could no longer meet his dull eyes, or stare at his thin features, or take in the confused way he was looking at him. Because it reminded Katsuki of his words, it reminded Katsuki of what he had done for so many years, and, most of all, it reminded Katsuki of what *Deku* had done for him, despite everything Katsuki put him through.

And yeah, if any fucker dared to ask him for proof of how much he had fucking changed in the past two months, that was the best one: the fact that, for the first time in the history of fucking *ever*, Katsuki Bakugou actually felt guilty and sorry for what he had done to Izuku Midoriya.

Great, what a fucking shit show. If it hadn't been for one month of anger management therapy, Katsuki would have thrown a tantrum right then and there at this realization. After all, when had he become such a weak, wimpy loser? Letting himself feel *guilty* and *sorry* for putting someone like Deku in his *place*? What in the goddamn fuck was he even thinking? The nerd should be fucking *grateful* that Katsuki had pushed him to his fucking limit! He wouldn't have gotten farther and managed to get where he was if it hadn't been for him! He wouldn't have been chosen by All Fucking Might, the symbol of fucking *peace*, if it hadn't been for him!

Yeah… That excuse didn't sound as right as it used to.

And well, in a way, that was probably the truth, right? Deku wouldn't be where he was if it hadn't been for Katsuki. In a *fucking* hospital bed, that is.

Deep down, despite the fact that he still had trouble admitting it, Katsuki knew his feelings were immature. The *least* he could feel after everything that happened between Deku and him was guilt, especially after the boy almost died because of him.

Especially because Deku was still barely hanging on, after everything.

Fuck. Katsuki probably owed him another apology. One he could actually hear, this time. One that wasn't shouted in the middle of his room during an emotional breakdown, for only Kirishima to hear.

But, even after everything, he still wasn't there yet.

He just… wasn't. He couldn't be.

Katsuki looked away from Deku in anger, because he couldn't bear to face the consequences of his actions any longer (which, hey, was *another* first. Katsuki never had trouble facing anything before).

(Except for what was right in front of him).

"K-K-Ka… K-Ka…ccha…", Deku attempted to speak, worried about Katsuki's sudden silence and obvious mood change. The nickname was one of the few words he could properly pronounce so far, and even that was still lame. The sound of it revolted Katsuki, especially because he knew that he was the one to blame for Deku speaking like that.

He stood up from his chair, feeling the need to just get the fuck away from there and get his thoughts in line. That seemed to be a common effect of being around Deku, recently – confusion, and brainstorms, and epiphanies he wasn't really fond of. Whenever Katsuki spotted Deku's shitty, nerdy face lying on that damn hospital bed, all his brain seemed to be able to do was freak the fuck out and start overthinking about shit Katsuki would much rather leave untouched. And, though he had no idea why the fuck this was happening, he *did* know that, sometimes, it was better to walk away before he ended up doing something stupid.

He didn't know what sort of stupidity he could end up doing, but he knew it was a risk anyway.

He pushed his chair back to the corner of the room so that it wouldn't be in anyone's way and finally turned to meet Deku's eyes, ready to make up whichever excuse the boy deemed acceptable enough to let him leave without making a fuss. And yeah, surely, the thought of cutting his visit short just because staring at Deku's face had made him freak out *sucked*, because he fucking missed the nerd despite knowing better than to feel that way, but Katsuki's heart was racing and he was feeling too much shit at once. He needed a fucking break.

Are you ok?, Deku signed at him, a concerned look on his face. His movements were still too rusty and slow, but at least he had learned how to sign a few things properly.

"Yeah, I'm fine", Katsuki said, standing beside the bed. His face probably looked more hostile than his words. "I just remembered I got a lot of shit to do for class tomorrow".

Izuku's frown never faltered as he continued to stare at Katsuki with confusion and worry.

"D-D-D… D-Did… I – I…", he attempted to say, but his tongue failed him. He sighed in frustration before lifting his fisted hand to his chin, only his thumb and his pinky sticking out.

He was probably trying to ask Katsuki if he had done something wrong, because he was a dumb motherfucker with a hero complex. Katsuki rolled his eyes before crossing his arms above his chest.

"Stop thinking so much of yourself, nerd. I just remembered I'm busy; that's all there is to it", he said sharply, glaring at Izuku.

The boy seemed hesitant and still worried, but he nodded subtly, staring up at Katsuki. He signed the word "*tomorrow*" in that rusty, amateur way of his, to which Katsuki rolled his eyes again and shook his fist down and up twice, indicating "*yes*". Yes, he would fucking visit Deku tomorrow, like he had been doing every day for the past week. Did the fucker really need to ask the same damn question every time Katsuki bid his goodbye? As if he was afraid each of Katsuki's visits would be his last?

"But don't expect me to show up before the sun is down; you know damn well I can't stand those annoying fucking friends of yours", Katsuki added with a grumpy look.

Deku offered him a tired, weak smile at this. In fact, he looked exhausted – which was a common look, these days, but it still pissed Katsuki off.

"Go catch some sleep, nerd. I'll tell the old woman I'm leaving on my way out so she can send someone to keep an eye on you", Katsuki announced, walking away from the bed.

Deku frowned again, something akin to tired indignation appearing on his face. He raised his shaky, weak hand and did the sign for "*grown up*", which sent an obnoxious, mocking laugh to Katsuki's lips.

"Oh, cut the bullshit, Deku. The day I'll be convinced that you can take care of yourself is the day I'll fucking die", he snorted.

Izuku's frown deepened and he shook both his fists down and up in front of him a couple times, trying to emphasize he was able to take care of himself. Katsuki rolled his eyes and scoffed.

"Yeah, says the guy in the hospital bed", he commented. Izuku looked like he wanted to respond, but didn't know how, and the moment he opened his mouth to try and speak Katsuki cut him short. "Don't fucking try it, shitty Deku. Even your mom agrees with me, or else she wouldn't have asked me to look after your dumb ass that day we went visiting her", Katsuki pointed out.

Izuku stared up at him with a blank, exhausted face. *This fucker needs to catch some sleep before his brain has a fucking kernel panic*, Katsuki thought.

"Just shut your damn eyes and get some rest. I'll ask the old woman to send someone in so you don't choke on your own spit while you sleep", Katsuki announced, turning off the lamp beside Deku's bed in a decisive way that left no place for a discussion.

Izuku looked like he wanted to protest, but before he could even open his mouth, Katsuki was already halfway across the hospital room and out.

His therapist stared at him with a curious look, her legs crossed and two fingers supporting her chin.

She had long abandoned her notebook and her pen, since having her take notes during the sessions made Katsuki furious and certainly did nothing to contribute to the goal of the therapy, which was helping him manage his anger. He was almost sure that not taking any notes only made her job harder, but at least she knew better than to ignore his feelings.

She was his fucking therapist, after all. If there was one thing she was required to do, that thing was to acknowledge and respect his feelings, right?

"So you left because staying there with Midoriya-kun was making you…?", she encouraged, slightly lifting an eyebrow at him. Katsuki huffed out a breath, looking away.

"I don't know", he admitted, feeling angry and grumpy. "But I just needed to leave".

"Why?", she asked, patient.

Katsuki glared at her.

"Because I couldn't stand staring at his dumb face anymore".

She stared at him silently, and her expression did not change the slightest bit.

"Why?"

Katsuki groaned.

"What are you, a fucking four-year-old?"

Her eyebrow raised further. Katsuki sighed and fished a coin from his pocket, putting it in the swear jar that was sitting beside his couch.

They had made a deal, back in one of the earliest sessions – every time Katsuki used a swear-word during the sessions, he needed to put money in the swear jar. Once he was officially cleared out of the sessions by his therapist, he would be allowed to get the jar of money back and use it as he wished (since it was his fucking money in the first place).

According to Doctor Matsuo, this was a way to make Katsuki aware of when he used bad-words and thus try to control it, since he had a tendency to swear even in the presence of authority. Personally, Katsuki thought this was fucking stupid and a childish waste of time, but since the money would go back to him, and not to her, by the end of the sessions, he didn't argue too vehemently.

As he leaned back against the couch after putting the coin into the jar, he noticed she hadn't moved, still staring at him with that curious face and waiting for a response. He sighed.

“Look, seeing him like that just reminded me of why he’s there in the first fu–“, he paused, sighing. “*Freaking* place”.

“Because of the villain”, she provided, her tone almost challenging.

Katsuki glared at her.

“Yeah. *And* because he took the damn blow for me. And it’s not –“

“Jar”.

“*What*?”

“’Damn’ counts as a swear-word”.

Katsuki squinted his eyes.

“Are you fucking kidding me?”

“Oops. Jar again”.

“Seriously?”

“Yes”.

“You should put money in, too. You just repeated the word I said”.

“Which word?”

“The D-word”.

She stared at him, the hint of a smile on her lips, almost as if she had expected Katsuki to say ‘damn’ again.

“I suppose that’s fair”, she shrugged in defeat, grabbing her purse in order to fish some money out and placing several coins inside Katsuki’s jar, which was already almost full to the brim after just a month of sessions. He followed her and put two coins in for the two words he had said. “And I’m also glad you’re becoming more aware of foul language”.

“Well, wasn’t that the jar’s *fucking* point– god *damn* it”, he grunted in frustration. She openly smiled.

“Though you still need a bit more work”, she commented as he grumpily fished out more coins and shoved them inside the jar in anger. “But you were saying?”

“I don’t ever fu– *freaking* remember anymore”, he leaned back on the couch once more, glaring at the wall behind her and bouncing one of his legs.

“You were uncomfortable being with Midoriya because of the villain attack”, she provided. He rolled his eyes.

“Yeah, because the idiot took the blow for me”, he added.

“I thought we had agreed in previous sessions that this was Midoriya’s own choice, not yours”.

Katsuki glared at her.

“Yeah. Doesn’t change the fact that he’s an idiot for doing that”.

“Him being an idiot is out of your control, Bakugou-kun. You are responsible for the actions and thoughts that are –“

“Mine, yeah, I *know* that”.

He stared at him.

“But that’s not it, really”, he admitted, not meeting her eyes and glaring angrily at the window instead.

“Then what is it?”

He was silent for a while.

“I don’t get why he would do that”.

She tilted her head.

“Like we said –“

“Yeah, I *know* what we fucking said”, he interrupted her, already grabbing another coin for the jar. “And I know he did that because he chose to. What I mean is I don’t get why he doesn’t *hate* me”.

She stared at him, waiting for him to continue. He glared.

“He even went as far as telling me that he…”, he sighed, shaking his head.

Silence.

“That he what?”, she encouraged when it became clear he wasn’t about to continue.

Katsuki was silent for a few seconds before continuing.

“He said that despite the fucked-up shit I did to him”, he placed the coins inside the jar, “he… He loved me. His exact words were: ‘despite everything you did to me, I still love you. I always have’”.

Doctor Matsuo kept looking at him, waiting for him to continue. She didn’t look surprised.

There was nothing else Katsuki could say on the subject, so he stayed silent, glaring at the floor.

“And what did you say?”

“What?”

“In response. Did you tell him anything?”

Katsuki glared at her.

“No”.

“Why not?”

“Well, because what could I possibly fucking say when the guy I put down for years told me he loved me? ‘I love you back even though you’re a wimpy asshole’?”

“Jar”.

“Yes, I fucking *know*”.

“But do you?”

“You’re the one who said I was becoming more aware –“

“Not that, Bakugou-kun”.

Silence.

“Do you? Love him back, that is?”

Katsuki glared at her with the fury of a thousand suns.

“Why does that even matter?”

“It does. In fact, it could help you understand a lot”.

“There’s *nothing* to understand”.

“Yes, there is. You said you were confused as to why Midoriya doesn’t hate you”.

“Yeah, because it doesn’t make any fu– *freaking* sense”.

“If anything, it makes a lot of sense”.

He squinted his eyes at her.

She sighed, shifting positions on her chair.

“Bakugou-kun”, she said patiently, crossing her legs in a different position. “Midoriya-kun doesn’t hate you because he loves you”.

Katsuki scoffed.

“And I know that sounds like an obvious statement”, she continued, “but, from the information you’ve told me, it only makes sense. And, since Midoriya-kun’s feelings are already clear, since he told you about them himself, the real question at hands is… What are *your* feelings?”

Katsuki glared at her in silence.

“You said that seeing him in the state he is makes you uncomfortable, because it reminds you of the fact that he took the blow in your place. Since we have agreed that him taking the blow in your place was an action that is out of your control, is there any other reason why seeing Midoriya-kun in a hospital makes you uncomfortable?”

Just pray that you’ll be born with a quirk on your next life

Take a swan dive off the roof of the building

And fuck, Katsuki had been such a dumb fucking brat, such an idiot piece of petty shit, because what if Deku had actually done as he was told and jumped? What if the fucker had actually gone and killed himself? What if he listened to Katsuki after years and years of being called worthless, and useless, and *deku*, which was the epitome of all that, really, and killed himself because he didn’t think himself fit to be anything but the things Katsuki said he was? What if he had done *that*?

The weight of those words he had said years ago hadn’t really sunken in, hadn’t really been clear to Katsuki until he saw Deku sobbing and whimpering in pain on a hospital bed, until he saw Deku flatline, until he saw Deku actually dead. Not even back when Deku threw the words at his face, while he was still a shitty ghost glued to Katsuki, did the weight of his suggestion become so real and evident. Because he had really done that – he had really told Deku to kill himself, to just go and *die,* and it took him literal *years* to realize how fucked up that had been.

It took watching Deku at death’s door because he had sacrificed his shitty ass for Katsuki to realize how fucked up that had been.

And he couldn’t really apologize for that, because what could he possibly say? How would he possibly look? What could he possibly *do* to make up for his past behavior?

How could he possibly make up for the fact that he had told Deku to take his own damn life over something as stupid as a quirk?

And how the *fuck* could Deku still love him after something like *this*? How the fuck could Katsuki say he wanted to be a hero, when he told a helpless, quirkless boy he should commit suicide for being different?

“Bakugou-kun?”, Doctor Matsuo called, because Katsuki had been sitting in silence without doing anything other than glare at the floor for several moments, not answering her question. He looked up at her at the call of his name, and he was almost sure that she could see it in his eyes that the train of thoughts that accompanied that matter was too long and complex to be unfolded in just one session.

“I don’t wanna talk about it”, Katsuki settled for saying, and she promptly nodded her acknowledgment.

“That is fine”, she reassured him. “What would you like to talk about?”

“Nothing”, he responded before he could put much thought about it. Doctor Matsuo took a glimpse at her wristwatch.

“We still have fifteen minutes left until the appointment is over”, she announced matter-of-factly. “Why don’t you tell me a bit about Kirishima-kun, then?”

Katsuki pursed his lips into a stern, displeased line. Apparently, there was not one single subject he could talk about to this woman without feeling pissed off.

“I’m still giving him the cold shoulder”.

“Why?”

He sighed, fed up. He wanted to go back to his bedroom.

“Because he was an asshole and he pissed me off”.

She shifted on her chair again.

“Do you think he was wrong, though?”

“The hell does that mean?”

“Jar”.

“Hell is not a swear-word”.

“He said he would not let you beat him as a way to relieve your stress anymore. Do you think that was a wrong decision?”

“Oh my *god*. I never *beat* him. We *sparred*. That’s fucking different”.

“Ja–“

“Yes, I *know*”.

She stared at him.

“But you *did* let your anger out by fighting him, right?”

“Yeah, and he knew that from day one. It’s not like I tricked him into it or something”.

“And do you think that is a healthy way to deal with your anger, considering all the methods we have discussed so far?”

Katsuki looked away, annoyed.

“Do you think physical violence is the answer?”

“I wasn’t being *physically violent* to him”, he tried to defend himself. “We were sparring. We were *training*. That’s fucking different. It’s another whole fucking context”.

She didn’t even remind him of the jar this time.

“Kirishima-kun doesn’t seem to agree with that, or he wouldn’t have asked you to stop”.

“He didn’t ask me for shit. He simply told me he wouldn’t spar with me anymore, without even asking me about it first”.

“He prioritized his feelings”.

“Yeah, like the selfish asshole he is”.

“Don’t you think you did the same thing, by sparring with him as a way to relieve your anger, *and* by leaving Midoriya-kun earlier than usual at the hospital?”

Katsuki glared at her.

“Don’t you think you have been prioritizing your feelings over others’ for a long while, now?”

Katsuki continued to glare at her.

“I –“, he started, angry. “– don’t even know what my fucking feelings *are*”.

“And yet, from what you’ve told me, you seem to always put them first anyway”.

Silence.

“I’m not reproaching you”, she clarified after a few moments of tense silence. “Or trying to make you feel like you are to blame. I am merely trying to help you see that the more you run away from your feelings, the hardest it will become to acknowledge them when you have to”.

Katsuki glared at her.

“Why don’t you try to empathize with what Kirishima-kun must be feeling? Perhaps, if you try to understand what he must have thought when he said what he said to you, you can understand his motives better”.

Katsuki looked away from her, leg still bouncing.

“Is the time up yet?”, was all he offered as a response.

Dr Matsuo sighed, removing her glasses.

“You can go”, she announced. “But do put some thought into what I told you. I think it will clarify a lot for you”.

Katsuki immediately got to his feet and made his way to the door without looking at her or even pretending to acknowledge her words, but before he could barge out, she added:

“And don’t think I’ve forgotten about those last curses”.

He stopped on his tracks, turning on his heels to glare at her before rolling his eyes in defeat and making his way to the jar, depositing one coin for each swear-word he hadn’t paid for yet.

After all, a deal was a deal.

He set his tray down on the table more loudly than he had intended, calling the attention of the group of friends sitting by it and making them look up at him in surprise, all conversation dying.

They stared at him in stunned silence for what felt like an eternity of judgement, and Katsuki simply stood there, staring back at each of their dumb faces, his tray already before the seat he was standing behind.

Then, without further ado or any kind of invitation, he pulled the chair and sat down, grabbing his *hashi* and starting to eat as if he hadn’t been eating by himself for weeks, now. All of his friends’ eyes were glued on him.

“Bakugou…?”, Sero was the first one to break the silence. Katsuki stared up at him, chewing a mouthful of food.

“*What*?”, he asked with his mouth still full, his tone almost daring the boy to question his presence there.

Katsuki had been eating by himself for a while, now, ever since Deku woke up and was put back into a coma. Ever since Deku woke back up again. And it wasn’t only because he felt like being alone and away from his friends’ loud talking when there was so much at stake, but also because he couldn’t stand the looks they gave him, as if he deserved pity for some damned reason. They had started to act differently around him ever since Deku’s soul was detached from his, and Katsuki hated it. He’d rather be alone than have to deal with that sugarcoated behavior.

Kirishima had been the only one who still tried to keep him company sometimes, but Katsuki had made it clear to his best friend that he wouldn’t mind if he wanted to sit with their friends at their table during lunch. That meant Kirishima’s presence with him at UA’s cafeteria was

divided – sometimes, he'd sit with Katsuki for half of their lunch time; sometimes, he would alternate the days in which he sat and didn't seat with him.

After their more-or-less-fight, Katsuki's desire to have lunch with his friends became even more dormant and solitude became a better, more constant option than ever, especially because Kirishima left him the fuck alone and didn't bother sitting with him anymore. In fact, Katsuki had even changed his lunch habits in order to arrive at the place during a timespan when his friends weren't around, just so that he could have some peace and quiet.

Peace and quiet was something he hadn't gotten ever since he got stuck with Deku 24/7. Now the boy was gone, that seemed to be all Katsuki could get.

It made him a bit sick of peace and quiet, but he had been too proud to do something about it.

But his therapist's words had left their mark in his brain, and he couldn't deny that, yeah, even though he still thought Kirishima had been an asshole, that didn't mean he was entirely in the wrong. Perhaps Katsuki *could* try to find a way to let his anger and frustration out in a manner that didn't involve fighting Kirishima. Just because he was the only one who could take his strength, it didn't mean he should.

(Plus, he missed the motherfucker. And he was at a point of his life where he knew better than to try and deny that obvious fact).

So yeah, maybe he could sacrifice the peace and quiet he had grown to loathe so much and go back to actually having lunch with a bunch of annoying people who talked too loud about things that were too meaningless. But Katsuki had grown used to that sort of thing over the time he had spent at UA, and maybe, just maybe, he could bring himself to admit that this loud shit-talk didn't bother him nearly as much as he pretended it did.

It did cause feedback on his hearing aid sometimes, though, so the second and only thing he said after sitting down by the table, without looking at any of their faces and in the middle of taking another bite of his food, was:

"If you fuckers start screaming or laughing too loud, my hearing aid gets feedback, and let me tell you I'll yank this shit out of my ear and shove it down each of your individual throats if that happens".

They all continued to stare at him, and Katsuki continued eating.

"Uh… Sorry, man, we didn't know that", Sero was the one who spoke up, again. They all nodded in agreement at the apology, and Katsuki continued not meeting any of their eyes.

"We really didn't know", Mina backed Sero up. "Sorry".

"Is that why you haven't been sitting with us?", Kaminari asked bluntly, which resulted on Mina elbowing him on his side with harshness. "Ouch!", he hissed, but other than that, remained silent.

“We promise we’ll be more careful from now on!”, Mina promised with a smile. They all nodded and hummed their agreement to her words.

Katsuki looked up at them. Mina and Sero were smiling widely at him, whereas Kaminari was still rubbing the sore spot on his ribs where Mina had hit him and Kirishima…

Well. Katsuki didn’t look at his face to know what he was doing. He couldn’t just yet.

He bowed his head and continued to eat his food in silence. He could feel Kirishima’s eyes glued to him, and he was the only one who hadn’t said a word ever since Katsuki arrived at the table.

Yeah, fuck that. Katsuki knew the boy deserved a proper, individual talk, since he was his closest friend from the group. He couldn’t expect to just sit at the table and have Kirishima go back to kissing his ass in a minute. He would have to deal with that later, if not after he was done with his food, then after he was done with all his obligations for the day.

I’m not prioritizing my damn feelings, Katsuki told the voice in his head that reminded him of Doctor Matsuo’s words from earlier. *I’m just making sure I don’t discuss my personal business with Kirishima in the middle of the dining hall, in front of a bunch of nosy people*. Kirishima would feel uncomfortable with that, and so would Katsuki and everyone else involved. In a way, he was prioritizing *Kirishima’s* feelings, not his own. On your fucking *face*, Doctor Matsuo.

They were all silent for a while, as if waiting to see what would happen next, now that Katsuki was back to sitting with them. However, once almost a minute of silence passed and Katsuki was still silently chewing up his food without looking at any of them, like he always did, they all decided that the best course of action would be to just go on about their businesses normally, as if nothing had changed between them over the past month. Katsuki didn’t look so inviting in the terms of talking about why he had isolated himself just yet, and his friends knew better than to try and push that subject.

“So… Like I was saying, uh, the makeup idea didn’t work really well, but I’m sure we’ll figure something out!”, Mina started, going back to the subject they had been discussing prior to Katsuki’s arrival. “Yaomomo suggested trying to make something with her quirk…”

And yeah, if he tried really hard, he could almost pretend he hadn’t lost a month-worth of meaningless conversation. Despite all the things that had changed, not just inside but also outside himself, the world seemed to still be the same. Which, quite frankly, frightened him – it seemed like he was an entirely different person, now, even though he was still in the process of improving some things about himself. An entirely different person, living in an old, static world.

Because at the end of the day, Sero and Kaminari still made inappropriate jokes, Mina still ranted for hours about nothing in particular, and Kirishima still worried about him. And, in all honesty, knowing that this aspect of life would never change, no matter how hard of hearing, sensitive, or thoughtful he became, gave Katsuki the tiniest bit of comfort.

There was nothing new under the sun.

He fell on his back against the floor, panting heavily and sweating like a pig. His damp clothes were clinging to his skin and the air surrounding him smelled strongly of nitroglycerin.

All Might appeared above him, offering him a hand to help him get up. Katsuki stared at it with indifference as he struggled to regain his breathing, but he eventually took it, accepting the aid to get back to his feet. Once he was standing up, he hunched forwards and leaned his hands on his knees, still panting. After all, he had just pushed a fucking truck all the way up a slope using his bare hands.

“You are doing great, Bakugou shonen”, All Might encouraged him, placing a supportive hand on his shoulder. Katsuki didn’t have the strength to shrug it off, so he reluctantly accepted the touch while trying his best to pretend he wasn’t freaking out on the inside for being praised by *All Might*, his fucking childhood hero.

“Could have done it faster if you hadn’t talked so much”, he protested breathlessly, just because he felt like saying something petty. All Might tapped his shoulder.

“This exercise didn’t rely on speed, but on strength”, the symbol of peace told him before removing his hand from Katsuki’s shoulder and taking a step back.

“Yeah, you tell that to people who are in the middle of a villain attack and see a truck flying in their direction”, Katsuki retorted.

“Hopefully, when the time comes, they will not rely on One For All to save them”, All Might told him. Katsuki snapped his head towards the man with an angry glare.

“The hell is that supposed to mean?”, he asked sharply. All Might stared at him.

“I mean that when you become a pro hero, One For All will already be back with Midoriya shonen, and you will be able to save people using your own quirk. However, for as long as you borrow this power, you need to adapt your body in order to bear it. The physical training your quirk requires is different from the physical training One For All requires – which is why, when you save victims from a truck, you’ll surely do something other than push it up a hill”.

Katsuki took a step closer to All Might, his red face glistening with sweat.

“Sure as hell I’ll do something else. I’ll blow the damn truck out of the way”, he said through gritted teeth. “And I’m not *borrowing* anything. I’m safekeeping it”.

All Might tilted his head to the side.

“I’m not the one who needs this shit. I only took it so that your precious little heir didn’t snap in half trying to process it. I’d only be *borrowing* it if I *needed* it, which I don’t”, he spat. The words sounded incredibly harsh to his own ears, but Katsuki only acknowledged that once they were out of his mouth.

All Might stared at him.

“Of course”, was all he said, in a tone that Katsuki didn’t know how to read, but that was certainly less cheerful that it had been a moment ago.

They walked down the hill together and in silence, heading back to UA grounds. Katsuki could feel the tension growing between himself and Deku’s mentor – *his* mentor – , and he was painfully aware that he probably owed the man an apology, if not for speaking so harshly about Deku’s situation, then for being disrespectful to an authority figure. However, before he could figure out a way to voice his apology without simultaneously sounding like a wimpy, coward little shit, All Might broke the silence first.

“Bakugou shonen… Are you sure about my earlier proposal?”

And fuck if it didn’t seem like All Might was going out of his way to make Katsuki angry. Seriously?!

“Yes”, Katsuki answered simply, sharply, all desire to apologize being immediately obliterated from his brain. He felt stupid for even considering it in the first place.

All Might sighed.

“I think it would be –“

“There’s no point in training how to use this shit. I don’t *plan* on using it”, he cut the man off abruptly.

Because All Might had offered to teach him how to use One For All, instead of just giving him a specific training to maintain a suitable physical shape for the quirk. And Katsuki had refused it, without hesitating or missing a beat – because it was true. He didn’t *plan* on using it. It wasn’t his, and he didn’t need it.

He didn’t want to know how to use it. It wasn’t his damn quirk to use.

“I’m only keeping it safe”, he added after a few moments of silence, because that was his *only* function in this One For All mess. To keep the fucking quirk safe so that, when Deku finally found the strength to get to his shitty feet, he would take it back and this damn subject would be over.

He wouldn’t use Deku’s quirk. He didn’t need it.

All Might looked conflicted.

“I am worried, my boy”, he admitted. “If you accidentally activate it, you could end up –“

“I’m not going to *accidentally activate* it”, Katsuki cut him short, snapping his head in order to glare at him. “What the hell do you take me for? I’m not Deku; I’ve had a quirk my whole damn life. I learned how to control this sort of crap”.

All Might stared at him, the conflicted look never leaving his face. It seemed like he couldn’t decide whether he should push Katsuki into doing what he thought was best despite the boy’s wishes, or if he should just leave the matter alone despite the risks Katsuki was under.

Because, at the end of the day, it wasn’t Katsuki’s fault he had ended up with One For All. He had been forced into that decision, into that responsibility, just so that he could save Izuku. In a way, he was doing Izuku a favor. It wasn’t right of All Might to demand anything from him.

Still, All Might didn’t want the boy’s spine to snap in two because he sneezed in a wrong way.

“It’s not my quirk, All Might”, Katsuki added, looking serious and decided. If All Might didn’t know the boy, he would have sworn there was a hint of a plea in his voice. “It’s *his* quirk. And I’m not gonna use it”.

All Might bowed his head, sighing in defeat. Young Bakugou was not an easy person to convince.

He would have to think of a better strategy later. For the moment, he would have to deal with his student’s stubbornness… And with the other matter he had at hands.

They continued to walk silently towards UA grounds, All Might trying to think of how to approach the subject he needed to approach and Katsuki trying his best to think about anything but One For All.

Because, his entire life, he bullied Deku for being quirkless. And now that Deku finally had a quirk, Katsuki had taken it from him. He basically stole it from him. And sure, he only did it because he didn’t have a choice, because Deku would have died otherwise, but fuck if it didn’t feel wrong.

At least the nerd seemed to be ok with that. He hadn’t shown any signs of anger, discomfort or betrayal so far. Katsuki honestly had no idea what he would do if Deku did that.

If Deku started hating him.

Because that would be a reasonable reaction, right? And, to be honest, Katsuki kind of deserved it. He couldn’t really figure out why Deku didn’t hate him in the first place, after everything he did to him. Why he kept praising him, and admiring him, and… and…

Loving him.

Because those were the only constants in his life, right? The only things he was always sure he would have. A strong quirk, a sharp mind, and Deku trailing after him, calling him *sugoi*.

He didn't know what he would do if he lost that.

Almost losing Deku had been enough. Katsuki didn't want to lose *Deku* too. The Deku who smiled at him. The Deku who praised and admired him. The Deku who looked at him like he was the light of the moon illuminating the darkest of nights.

The Deku who didn't hate him for all the fucked-up shit that he did, and who loved him despite it.

"Have you been visiting him?", All Might asked, breaking the silence and interrupting his thoughts. Katsuki realized they were just about to arrive at UA's front entrance, and that he had been lost in deep thought for half of the way.

He had been thinking about shitty Deku for half of the way, and fuck if that didn't feel frightening. When had the nerd occupied so much of Katsuki's thoughts before?

~~The past month, and the month prior, and every single day ever since he woke up from the coma~~ –

"I only ask because I haven't seen you around", All Might added when he didn't receive an answer from his student. Katsuki scoffed and turned to glare at the man, trying his best to push everything he was feeling back to the depths of his brain and focus on the conversation at hands.

"That's because I only go there after everyone is gone. I can't stand Deku's shitty friends".

"I see", All Might gave him a tiny smile that didn't quite reach his eyes. That'd been happening a lot, recently, which made Katsuki finally wonder about how All Might himself was holding up with this entire situation.

He thought about asking the man about it, but they arrived at UA grounds in that moment and the symbol of peace immediately stopped on his tracks, turning to face Katsuki.

"You have been helping him a lot in his recovery", All Might commented, placing a hand on Katsuki's shoulder again. His urge to shrug away from the touch was strong, but, for some reason, it didn't feel right to do so. Maybe All Might himself needed that comforting touch as much as Katsuki did. "Now I understand where he learned sign language from".

"He hasn't *learned* sign language, he sucks at it", Katsuki retorted grumpily despite himself, before staring at All Might again with a half-curious, half-angry look. He squinted his eyes. "He didn't say it was me?", he asked, because well, that was fucking weird. And Katsuki wasn't really comfortable with having his fucking credit stolen like that.

"He hasn't been saying much of anything, really", All Might shrugged in grief. "To be frank, I didn't realize that his gestures were sign language until now, when you told me you've been visiting him. We, as teachers, were required to learn it during training in order to attend all of our students' needs, but – well –", he scratched the back of his neck awkwardly.

"He sucks at it", Katsuki provided, repeating his previous words. All Might chuckled softly.

“Well. He has a long way to go”.

“That’s just a sugarcoated way to say he sucks at it”, Katsuki told him in a deadpan. All Might smiled at tapped his shoulder.

“I am sure that, with your help, he will improve in no time. You have been a great friend for him, Bakugou shonen”.

Katsuki stared straight ahead with a serious look on his face. Above them, the sun was a mixture of orange, purple, and pink as the sun set on the horizon and the night approached. The day had been hot, but now a cool breeze was coming along with the night and making Katsuki’s sweat-covered skin tingle with goosebumps.

He didn’t know what to say to that. Because was that what he was for Deku, now? A *friend*? After everything? After all the things they went through and that Deku forgot about, after all the things he said to him throughout their lives? After telling Deku to kill himself and not ever apologizing for it?

“You really thought I wasn’t visiting just ‘cause you never saw me there?”, Katsuki asked sternly instead, just to keep the silence from stretching too long. He didn’t look at All Might as he said those words, because, in a way, he knew why the man had thought he hadn’t been visiting. He had all the right to think that of Katsuki.

What a great fucking friend he was.

“I assumed you were, but I thought it would be better to ask”, All Might admitted.

Katsuki scoffed, looking at the man from the corner of his eyes.

“Why?”

All Might’s lips formed a thin line on his bony face before he replied.

“The connection you two created in that month you were together…”, he started, pensive. “That was something that I don’t think can be broken. Midoriya shonen needs you. More than ever. And something tells me that you need him, too”.

Katsuki looked away from All Might, his face contorted into his usual grumpy expression. He suppressed the urge to shout profanities at the man because of that statement.

“However…”, All Might continued, and Katsuki didn’t like the ominous tone his voice assumed. He turned his head to stare at the man, anticipation written all over his face. “Something has been concerning me”.

A pause. Katsuki waited for All Might to go on.

All Might gestured at Katsuki for them to move to a more reserved spot, where there would be no curious ears around, and Katsuki followed suit. When they came to a stop at a deserted corner, he stared up at the tall man, whereas All Might stared at the orange sky above them.

He looked like he was trying to find the right words to say whatever he needed to say to Katsuki.

“When asked, Midoriya shonen claims he remembers what happened before the coma, even if he can’t talk about it just yet”, All Might started, and well, Katsuki immediately hated where this was going. He didn’t interrupt. “But… In some instances, when I or someone else mention the events of the month he spent with you as a ghost…”

Katsuki’s face was blank.

“He seems to have no memory of it”.

Katsuki blinked up at All Might. All he could think about was the way Deku had looked utterly and completely confused when he mentioned the visit to his mom on the day before.

Katsuki had thought the fucker had just been slow due to tiredness and weakness. He had thought Deku just needed to take a nap before his brain shut itself down. He had never considered… He…

His face scrunched up into an angry expression. Anger had always been his go-to reaction in the first place – he was almost glad that much hasn’t changed, at least.

“That makes no fucking sense”, Katsuki huffed out a breath, snarling in suspicion. “Why the hell would he say he remembers the shit that happened if he *doesn’t* remember?”

All Might gave him an apologetic look.

“We can’t know for sure what he remembers until he’s able to speak again. Perhaps he remembers the villain attack, but not –“, All Might cut himself short. Katsuki squinted his eyes.

“But not what?”

A pause.

“*What*?”, Katsuki urged, heart beating fast in his chest. He longed for and loathed the answer to that question.

“But not what came after it”.

Katsuki stared at him.

“You’re saying he doesn’t remember his time as a shitty *ghost*?”

All Might sighed again.

“That is just speculation”.

“You seem to be fucking sure of that, though”.

“I’m not sure of anything, shonen. But, given that One For All is a quirk related intimately with one’s soul…”

Katsuki felt his face go pale and his stomach drop.

All Might couldn’t be saying what he thought he was saying.

“So you mean…”, Katsuki swallowed dry, staring up at the hero. All Might looked at him with sorrowful eyes.

“It’s safe to assume that, since you are the bearer of One For All, now, you are also the bearer of Midoriya shonen’s memories from his time as a ghost. After all, it was his soul that acquired those memories”.

Katsuki scoffed, breathing sharply. He could feel the anger boiling in his blood; he could feel the way his face was becoming contorted with fury. Why the fuck hadn’t he thought of this? Why the fuck hadn’t he noticed there was something off about shitty Deku’s behavior? Why the fuck had he become so fucking slow and oblivious?

“So all I gotta do is give the nerd his quirk back and his memories will return?”, he asked, mindful not to let something as ludicrous as *hope* to be evident in his voice. Why did he care so much whether Deku remembered that shit or not? It wasn’t like it mattered.

It didn’t matter. It couldn’t matter.

It shouldn’t matter.

All Might looked at him with all the pity in the world, and Katsuki hated it.

“You can’t give his quirk back yet”.

Katsuki stared at him.

“He needs to recover and regain an appropriate physical form, first”.

Katsuki stared at him.

He didn’t know what to think of that. He didn’t know how to feel about that.

“But, Bakugou shonen –“, All Might reached out for him, probably sensing Katsuki was becoming distraught. “As I said, it’s merely speculation –“

“No”, Katsuki shook his head angrily, decided, taking a step back so that All Might couldn’t grab a hold of him. “You wouldn’t be telling me this shit if it was only *speculation*”.

All Might stared at him in silence, and then it dawned on Katsuki. He stared in shock and betrayal and anger, anger, so much anger.

“You’re trying to prepare me, aren’t you?”

Silence. All Might bowed his head slightly.

“You’re trying to give me a heads-up so that I don’t freak the fuck out on Deku when I find out”, he scoffed. “What? You think I’m gonna scream at him while he lies on a hospital bed? You think I’m gonna call him names and make him upset and fucking *hurt* him?”

All Might breathed heavily.

“Is *that* what you take me for?”, he half-shouted, knowing well that All Might wasn’t wrong to think that.

“In the state Midoriya shonen is in, I don’t think –“, All Might paused, sounding tired. He wasn’t meeting Katsuki’s eyes. “I don’t think he can handle a heartbreak”.

Katsuki huffed out a breath. His eyes were tingling, for some reason, and drawing deep breaths was becoming hard. His face was a mess of anger and offense, and his hands kept curling into fists.

“Yeah, because that’s all I ever do”.

“Bakugou shonen –“

“No, fine, I *get* it”, Katsuki scoffed angrily, hating how wobbly his voice came out. “I’m not trying to victimize myself, that’s really all I ever fucking do to Deku. It’s only fit you’d think that, right? It’s only fit anyone would. It’s *right* you would”.

All Might stared at him in shock.

“Because guess what, that’s *exactly* what I would have done”, he continued, snarling and furious in an almost feral way, his throat thick with emotion. “I would have fucking screamed and yelled and thrown a damn fit. But *not* at him”.

Silence.

“Not at him. I’m not that person anymore. And I don’t fucking know what kind of person I am now, but –“

Take a swan dive off the roof of the building

He swallowed dry, heart thumping painfully inside his chest.

All Might continued to stare at him, looking almost shocked.

I think he wanted you to be the hero he thought he would never get to be

“You know what, *whatever*”, Katsuki scoffed, turning on his heels and walking away with a wet sniff.

He barged into the hospital room only to find Deku lying on the bed and Icy Hot sitting by his side.

They both stared at Katsuki with surprise as he marched his way into the room and towards Deku's bed. It was only reasonable – this wasn't one of Katsuki's regular visiting hours, he had just kicked the door in, his hair was disheveled, his face was red from effort, and his clothes were drenched in sweat and clinging tightly to his skin. Overall, he must have looked like a frantic mess.

Todoroki immediately got to his feet and gave Katsuki a warning look.

"Bakugou".

"Leave".

"What's going on?"

"I said *leave*, Icy Hot".

He gave Todoroki a meaningful look that wasn't entirely rid of anger, but that wasn't coated in it, either. They had been in better terms ever since that day at the gym, and they had even trained together in other occasions when opportunity arose, but that didn't mean they were the best of friends, and that certainly didn't mean Katsuki was about to justify himself to the fucker.

Todoroki must have seen that in his eyes, because he sighed, and took a step closer to Katsuki.

"Did All Might talk to you?", he asked in a half-whisper, careful to lean closer to Katsuki's good ear. That made his blood boil.

"You mean to tell me he talked to you *first*?", Katsuki snapped, glaring daggers at Todoroki. From the bed, Izuku's eyes darted between them in confusion.

"No. I was there when he and Recovery Girl reached the conclusion. I hadn't noticed it until they discussed the subject", Todoroki provided, his voice low as if not to be overheard, sounding more patient than he usually was to Katsuki. He probably had the decency to realize how shaken Katsuki must have been by the news that he had lived through an entire month with Izuku, only to have the boy forget about everything. "I was the one who suggested he spoke to you before you figured it out on your own. You're not exactly thick, so it was just a matter of time before you did".

Katsuki glared at Todoroki. Todoroki stared back at him with a serious, but almost sympathetic look on his face. It was still cold, though. Threateningly cold.

“Don’t do anything stupid. He’s still recovering –“

“I fucking *know* that –“

“*Bakugou*”, Todoroki interrupted sharply, his tone leaving no space for a discussion. “*Anything* could have a negative effect on his health, and you don’t look exactly under control right now”.

Katsuki fumed at him, furious, his teeth getting exposed to the cool air of the room as he snarled. He knew the reaction only proved Icy Hot’s point, but he was past beyond the point of caring.

“Out of my way, Icy Hot”.

“I’m serious”, Todoroki stopped Katsuki from walking past him by pushing a hand against his chest decisively. “You should take a break. Go to the bathroom, cool your head down”.

Katsuki grabbed the front of Todoroki’s shirt and pulled him closer to himself so that they could be at the same eye-level, his grip firm and his eyes scorching.

“I’ve got this. I’m not gonna make him cry himself to sleep or some shit”, he said simply, his voice a growl. “So just piss the hell off”.

Then he shoved Todoroki away and walked over to Izuku’s bed without sparing him another look.

Izuku stared at him with fearful eyes and a confused frown, and as soon as Katsuki’s attention was focused on him, and not on Todoroki, he immediately signed “*what’s the matter?*” with his shaky fucking hands to the angry boy. Katsuki stopped in front of his bed, still sweaty and red, and, aware that Todoroki was still in the room with them, said:

“How’re you doing, nerd?”, in the most neutral voice he could muster – which, in all honesty, was just as angry as his usual voice and ended up coming off scolding. Izuku frowned, and shakily signed that he was fine. Katsuki tried to sound more patient as he added: “Good. Did you sleep well? Are you rested and shit?”

Izuku’s frown deepened, but he nodded, almost hesitating. He looked at Todoroki, who was still lingering in the room as if ready to step in should Katsuki lose his cool, and then back at Katsuki.

He seemed confused, and a bit scared. Not of him – but of what Katsuki wanted to tell him. Deciding it would be better to cut the bullshit, Katsuki sighed and bowed his head.

“Listen up, Deku. I’m gonna ask you a series of questions, you’re gonna answer them with yes or no. Got it?”, he demanded sharply. Izuku seemed to get even more nervous, but nodded his agreement anyway. “Fine. First question: do you remember what fucking happened after you took the villain’s blow for me?”

Izuku's face paled considerably and he didn't answer.

"Yes or fucking *no*, Deku?", Katsuki insisted aggressively, banging a hand on the edge of Izuku's bed. Todoroki placed a hand on Katsuki's shoulder at the same time Izuku's eyes pooled with tears.

"Bakugou, you shouldn't –"

"Shut the fuck up, Icy Hot!", Katsuki snapped, batting Todoroki's hand away and turning back towards Izuku, who flinched.

Katsuki stopped on his tracks.

Deku had flinched.

Was Deku…?

Was Deku fucking scared of *him*?

And yeah, ok, *empathy* or some shit like that, and Katsuki realized what a sight he must have been for Deku. Red in the face, dripping sweat, barging into his room out of nowhere at a weird hour with nothing but rage and shouting when he had shown the boy a completely reverse behavior so far. Because yes, he still called Deku names, and he hadn't been entirely patient with him ever since he woke up either, but he hadn't yelled at the boy so far, not even once. He hadn't shouted, he hadn't gotten angry, he hadn't been hostile. And he *was* being hostile right now. If anything, he must have looked like he was about to fucking attack Deku at his shitty hospital bed.

Katsuki took a deep breath, then another, then another. Tried to remember his therapist's tips for calming down in moments of outbursts. Forgot all of them.

"Deku. I'm not mad or anything. And I won't be mad at you if you answer no", he said, trying to sound calmer but barely managing, since his words still came off as angry. The best course of action was keeping a cool head and making his intentions clear. Right? "So just tell me. Yes or no. Do you remember what happened?"

Izuku stared at him for what felt like an eternity before shaking his head no.

And yeah, if Katsuki didn't know what he had been feeling about this entire shitshow before… He was fucked, now.

(He remembered being punched in the stomach by All Might. It didn't compare to this.)

"J-J… J-Jus… J-Just…", Izuku stuttered, and then raised his hands to sign "*wake up*".

"You just remember taking the blow, and then you woke up?", Katsuki provided through gritted teeth, jaw tense, vein popping in his temple. He could sense Todoroki looming behind him.

Izuku nodded, looking almost embarrassed. Katsuki sighed, angry, looking away from Deku and lowering his head. He placed both hands on his waist.

Both Izuku's and Todoroki's eyes were glued on him, but Katsuki looked anywhere but at them. He tried to list all the times he mentioned something from Deku's time as a ghost to him after he woke up, silly things such as the visits to his mom or the pillow fort, and the number was enough to make him feel pathetic and ridiculous. There had he been, blabbering nonsense to the fucker's ears, and he hadn't – he hadn't fucking even –

"Why didn't you fucking tell me that, you idiot?", Katsuki spat, glaring at Deku. "Why did you let me talk about all that shit without saying you had no fucking idea what I was going on about?"

Izuku's breathing got heavier and his eyes were still shining. He seemed disturbed. He looked small, like that, or at least even smaller – and the sight only made Katsuki's chest feel even tighter than it already was.

"I – I…", Izuku tried, but nothing came out. Todoroki stepped in again.

"He can't *speak*, Bakugou", the boy provided, sounding angry. Katsuki turned to face him, only to be met with Icy Hot's cold, disapproving gaze. "You're making him distressed".

And it dawned on him, with the suddenness and the strength of a car crash, that if Deku didn't remember about the shitshow of his month bound to Katsuki, if he didn't remember about everything they had gone through – hell, if he didn't even remember about the fever; if the *last* thing he remembered really was the villain attack… Then that mean he didn't know Katsuki had One For All.

He didn't fucking know he had given Katsuki his consent. That Katsuki had taken his quirk from him. That he… That he was quirkless again. Temporarily, yes, but quirkless. Because of Katsuki.

So *that's* why he wasn't angry. You can't be angry at something you don't know.

He stared at Deku again, who looked thin and small and sickly pale on the hospital bed. His eyes looked big and wet and sad and… and…

There wasn't a hint of anger in them.

Just concern.

Katsuki breathed in, breathed out. This was all too much.

He turned on his heels and left.

He spent almost an hour in his hot shower, the environment be fucked, and when he stepped out his fingers were all crinkled up and his skin felt tight against his bones.

He didn't think about it – he dried himself up, put his clothes on, sat by his studying desk, did his homework, watched an online class. Once he was done, he lied in bed and completely ignored the constant vibrations of his phone in order to turn on his side and stare at the wall.

His plan was to just stare at the damn thing until sleep caught him, but his brain had other ideas. Like thinking about Deku and what his lack of memory fucking meant, for example.

So, to be chronological: Deku takes the blow for him during the fight. Deku's soul becomes attached to his, resulting on a series of developments in their relationship. Katsuki goes after the fucking villain, kicks his ass, and almost loses Deku in the process.

Deku's soul is returned to his body, which is weak as fuck, and his damn quirk almost kills him. Katsuki takes One For All for himself in order to save the nerd's life. Deku has all sorts of fucking problems because of his weak sate, develops an infection, and almost dies from boiled-brains disease. He gets put into a coma, and when he wakes up…

He remembers none of the aforementioned things, except for the first one.

None of the days he spent with Katsuki. None of their discussions. None of the acknowledgements, none of the epiphanies, none of the fucking conclusions they reached regarding one another.

Nothing. Absolutely nothing. It was like shitty Deku's brain was a blank page, like he had been granted the gift of forgetfulness whereas Katsuki had to keep on living with the weight of the knowledge he had acquired in those past few months.

Wasn't that what death felt like, though? One person forgetting everything, and the other one living on with the memories?

Well. Deku *had* died. So that was only fit.

But what bothered him the most – what drove him up the walls the most – was what All Might had told him. That One For All was a quirk of the soul, and that Deku's memories from his time as a ghost resided within it.

Within Katsuki.

Which meant Deku's memories weren't gone forever. They would be returned to him once Katsuki returned him his quirk.

Which, in its turn, was a pain in his fucking *ass*.

Because honestly? Being a nice guy fucking *sucked*. Katsuki was fucking tired of it. He was aware of all the positive developments he had achieved and of the many ways in which he had improved, but it didn't feel fair that he had gotten so far while Deku got to forget all about that shit. He was in anger management therapy, for fuck's sake. And Deku could just shrug everything damn thing off and keep on living with the bliss of forgetfulness?

What Katsuki wouldn't give to forget about seeing Deku disappear in front of his very eyes, or about seeing Deku's heart stop and his body become limp from the lack of life.

What wouldn't he give to go back to being just an angry motherfucker who didn't give a shit about other people's feelings, who didn't bother about fucking empathy, who did what he wanted whenever he wanted without worrying about shit. What wouldn't he give to go back to being a selfish asshole who would *never* risk his career for someone like Deku.

And yet deep down, he knew he wanted none of those things – or, if he really wanted them, he couldn't have them. He had already crossed the event horizon, the point of no return – he wasn't sure when or how, but he had. He couldn't go back to the way he used to be anymore – not even if Deku never regained his memories, not even if there was no one around to hold him responsible for going back to his primordial state of being.

Because now he fucking knew how things worked. He had learned, not out of his own will but out of the soulbond, how it was to be on another person's shoes when it came to feelings. He had been forced to learn how to empathize, and now, even if he *wasn't* forced to do so anymore per say, he still ended up empathizing with people in a certain level. Which was why he had opted to be honest with his therapist, why he had gone back to talking with his shitty friends, why he decided to make peace with Kirishima, why he chose to stop being hostile to Icy Hot (most of the time).

And now, the petty, ridiculous, childish part of his mind kept screaming at him that he should be angry at Deku, because if shitty fucking Deku was allowed to go back to stage one, then he should be allowed to do that, too. Things were simpler at stage one. Less complicated. Why the fuck was Deku allowed to have something that he didn't have? Why was Deku allowed to have *peace*?

Well, it was only right he could have peace, wasn't it? Katsuki had tormented the guy his entire fucking life, it was about time the tables turned for them. It was just karma.

Still. Knowing that Deku didn't remember anything, knowing that Deku was a month-worth of steps behind him… That made him feel a bunch of stuff he couldn't name. And fuck if Katsuki had no idea how Deku would react once he found his quirk was no longer with him, but with Katsuki, of all people.

Would he be angry? Would he be sad? Would he be furious? Would he be betrayed? Katsuki had no idea. And he knew he would have to find out, eventually, but he wasn't looking forward to that day. Because learning the guy who always mocked him for not having a quirk had *stolen* his fucking quirk after he tried so hard to obtain it couldn't possibly be easy on Deku, especially in the fragile state he was in.

Oh, he could almost feel the painful twist in the chest and the discomfort at the bottom of the stomach that Deku would feel once he heard the words. Who would tell him? All Might? Katsuki himself?

Knowing the asshole, there was also a chance that he would be *glad* Katsuki had his quirk now. He would probably mumble something like '*I'm glad you have it, Kacchan, I'm sure you'll be even more amazing now!*', or whatever crap he enjoyed blabbering about all the time. And the thought of Deku being happy about this situation only made Katsuki dread the conversation even more. He'd rather have an angry Deku.

Because that's what Deku should feel towards him. Anger. Not happiness, or love, or whatever bubbly feeling he felt whenever he looked at Katsuki's direction. He should feel anger, and rage, and… And…

Ugh. Katsuki hated thinking about this. When had he become such a self-loathing asshole?

Fuck Deku. Fuck Deku's soul, fuck Deku's feelings, fuck Deku's quirk, fuck Deku in general. *He* was the reason why Katsuki couldn't conform himself with just anger anymore, and ended up resorting to other stupid feelings like *guilt* and *sorrow*. He'd better ask Earphone Girl for advice on shitty emo music at once, since he was becoming such an emotional piece of shit.

And yet, he couldn't stop thinking about the shitty nerd. And he *hated* it. He hated that he couldn't understand what he was feeling, or *why* he was feeling.

And that was the real problem he was having with empathizing, right? He rarely ever knew what *he* was feeling, how the fuck was he supposed to figure out what other people were feeling? Maybe his damn therapist was right and he should try to face his emotions, rather than running from them. Just like Kirishima had told him. Just like Deku had told him, a lifetime ago.

Yes, maybe that was the right thing to do. Because pretending the only things he ever felt were anger and rage wouldn't work anymore. He was way past that, now. No matter how much he hated that, he had changed – for the better or for the worse. In Katsuki's case, he couldn't quite decide which one was it.

So, yes, ok. Acknowledging feelings. Now that he was open to the idea, it shouldn't be too hard. He tried to concentrate and to look deep into himself, ready for an epiphany.

He stared at the wall for several moments. Nothing happened.

He squeezed his eyes shut and huffed out a breath. *Come on. Concentrate*.

Silence.

And then…

Nothing.

“God *damn* it”, Katsuki grunted in frustration, sitting up abruptly on the bed. Why the fuck did this feelings shit have to be so damn hard? Why couldn’t he just come to terms with his feelings and be *done* with it?

Why was he trying to do this shit, anyway? It was a waste of time. An utter waste of time.

But if I understand my feelings better, I’ll get to treat Deku better.

But why the fuck should I give a shit about how I treat Deku? And why the fuck would I want to treat him well?

Because I’ve already put the fucker through enough! I even went as far as telling him to kill himself, and he still tried to save my life like the asshole he is!

But that was his fucking choice, not mine, just like Doctor Matsuo said! I’ve got nothing to do with that! It’s not my fault he’s dumb!

Yeah, but he still doesn’t fucking hate me, even though he should!

That’s his fucking problem!

Well, that’s my problem too, since he’ll probably jump at the next opportunity to kill himself trying to save me!

And that will be his own damn fault!

Yeah, but I don’t want that to happen!

Why don’t I want that to happen?

Katsuki’s breath caught in his throat.

I… I…

Here goes nothing.

Wanting people to die is not heroic. And I want to be a hero.

But wasn’t I the guy who kept screaming “die!” at everything and everyone? Wasn’t I the guy who lost his hearing trying to murder a villain? What kind of fucking hero am I becoming? Is this the incarnation of victory?

(The hero he thought he would never get to be –)

Is that how low I have fallen? I’m gonna start shaping myself to meet Deku’s fucking standards, now?

But are those bad standards, though? He said I’m his image of victory. He loves All Might, after all, the greatest hero of them all, he…

He… He loves me.

He really does, doesn't he?

Katsuki covered his face with both hands, taking a deep breath.

So far, he hadn't taken those words to the heart. If anything, he had gone out of his way to pretend he hadn't heard them. But now? Now he couldn't keep denying it. He couldn't keep pretending Deku hadn't said them to him, loud and clear, clear as a day.

Deku loved him, and there was nothing Katsuki could do about it.

Before he knew better, he was on his feet, putting a pair of slippers on and marching out of his room in the middle of the night. He didn't care if it was past curfew. All he knew was that he needed to see Deku, needed to look at his ugly, thin face and figure out what the fuck it was he was feeling once and for all. It didn't matter that he was still confused shitless, or that his heart was thumping hard and fast into his chest as if he was about to enter combat, or that his past-self hated him for even giving a shit about Deku in the first place. For some reason, he had reached the conclusion that seeing Deku would be the solution to all his damn problems.

He arrived at the medical bay, which was obviously empty, considering the time. Katsuki wasn't even surprised that no one caught him out of bed – even the surveillance robots were probably asleep at a time like this (and Katsuki knew how to sneak past them in case they were active).

When he entered Deku's room, it was dark and silent, the only light in the place coming through the window and from the moon. Deku was alone in the room – Katsuki would have to talk to Recovery Girl about that, because the lying old hag had promised him she would make sure Deku always had someone around to keep an eye on him, lest he die in his damn sleep, and that obviously wasn't the case right now.

He approached the bed. Deku was fast asleep, his head tilted to the side and away from the light of the moon. His green curls were dark and dull in the darkness, looking more like they were black. And, due to the paleness of his face and the bluish hue of the moonlight, Deku's freckles stood out more than ever, looking like a constellation on his cheeks.

Katsuki found himself staring at the boy's sleeping form, watching the steady rise and fall of his chest. With due time, he found himself unable to look away, lest Deku's heart stop again if he did so.

And the idea on its own was fucking ridiculous, right? Because that wasn't how hearts fucking worked. Deku's heart didn't depend on Katsuki's eyes watching him sleep like a fucking creep in order to keep beating, otherwise it would stop every time Katsuki wasn't in the room. Deku didn't depend on him to live. Not anymore, at least.

Not anymore.

And this lack of rationality pissed him off to no end, because he wasn't like that. He could deal with becoming gentler, or more patient, or more understanding – he still felt like a

pathetic wimp for that, but no one seemed to judge him for it, and he could *cope*. But becoming dumb? That fucking *pissed* him. And, most of all, it didn't suit him.

He was a person who always thought before acting, who always calculated the odds before getting into a fight, who always planned things carefully and came up with thoughtful strategies. He never jumped into action without a plan at hands. No matter how ill-tempered and hot-headed he was, he *never* acted recklessly.

And yet he had lost his hearing because he almost killed a villain. Everything about that sentence sounded wrong.

And everything about that sentence had been for Deku.

The only exception for that seems to be Midoriya, of course, Aizawa sensei had told him. And he had been right.

And Kirishima had also been right. Katsuki *had* been moping, ever since what happened… happened. Being stuck with Deku had changed him, but being *without* Deku – that had changed him ever further.

And two months ago, Katsuki wouldn't have dreamed of this – of actually worrying about Deku, or caring about him, or fearing for his literal death. Two months ago, Katsuki wouldn't have *feared* anything. He would have stared death in the eyes and told her to go fuck herself, he would have laughed at it like he always did upon facing the worst of enemies, he would have despised her and told her to take Deku, it would be doing him a favor, things would be better off without him.

Take a swan dive off the roof of the building

Now…? Just thinking about taking his eyes off Deku made him freak the fuck out, because the fucker could kick the bucket at any given moment and no one would even notice until it was morning and it was too late.

And fuck it, fuck *this*, because Katsuki had always been the strongest, always been the best, always been the *bravest*. Until he watched Deku fucking die in front of him. And now…

Now he knew fear.

And it pissed the fuck out of him.

He didn't want it. He couldn't have it. He couldn't allow himself that weakness, because if he did so, if he allowed Deku to be his fucking Achilles's heel, then he would be exposed, and Deku would be exposed, and everyone would have their asses out in the open for the villains to screw it as they wished. Because if Katsuki cared about Deku, if Katsuki allowed himself to love him, then he would be putting the fucker at risk for the rest of his life. If Deku was willing to die for Katsuki when Katsuki treated him like shit, what would he do if Katsuki actually returned his feelings?

Wait… What?

Was he… Was he actually considering this possibility?

Because that was what Deku had meant when he said he loved Katsuki, wasn't it? That he was willing to give everything for him? That he was willing to *die* for him?

Did Deku feel the same, looking at Katsuki, as Katsuki did, looking at Deku? Did he feel that impending sense of doom? Did he feel fear? Did he feel that tightness in the chest, that confusion in the brain, that horrible feeling in the stomach like moths trying to break out?

Was *this* love?

If it was, then it was fucked up and Katsuki didn't want it. He didn't want love to make him weak, or vulnerable, or dumb. And, so far, if he was right, those were the only things that had happened to him because of it – weakness, failure, stupidity, recklessness, loss. He had almost lost Deku. He *had* lost Deku once, watching him disappear between his fingers, and then he had almost lost him for good, watching him die on that very room. And fuck if Katsuki didn't wish he could go back to feeling nothing but anger towards the nerd. Things were simpler back then.

But he couldn't go back, not anymore. He knew he couldn't. And he knew, right on that moment, that this shit would be the end of him.

Loving Deku was the internal fatal error from which his system could not safely recover.

"K… K-Ka…?", Deku tried to ask, and Katsuki nearly jumped out of his skin when he heard the voice, realizing the boy was awake. He hadn't noticed it, too focused on the steady rise and fall of his chest, rather than on his face. His eyes were glassy and sleepy, his face scrunched up in confusion. *That's all his fucking face ever does anymore*, Katsuki thought.

"Yeah", Katsuki said simply, voice low in order not to call unwanted attention. He stepped closer to the bed, being watched by Deku's big, green eyes. "Watcha doing awake, nerd?", he asked, managing to make his voice sound more like it was reproaching and less like it was afraid.

Deku opened and closed his mouth, before settling for making the sign for "*don't know*".

"Tch", Katsuki scoffed, glaring at Izuku. "You should go back to fucking sleep, then. It's late".

Izuku frowned at him, looking sleepy and confused, before shakily signing "*what are you doing?*" and "*here*". Before Katsuki could manage a response, Izuku did the signs for "*think*" and "*angry*". *What are you doing here? I thought you were angry*, probably.

Katsuki couldn't help but to snort out a laugh.

"When am I *not* angry, nerd?"

Izuku offered him a small smile that reached all the way to his eyes, even though he was still frowning slightly. He looked tired and weak.

“I just wanted to check on you. My visit earlier didn’t count for shit, and I was halfway sure that your lame ass would be upset I yelled at you or some shit like that”, he added, not meeting Deku’s eyes but not looking away from his general form, either.

Izuku frowned and did the sign for “*sorry*”. Katsuki sighed, rolling his eyes.

“The *fuck* are you apologizing for, asshat? Stop thinking everything has to do with you”.

Izuku lowered his gaze in embarrassment.

“Did Icy Hot explain anything to you after I left?”, Katsuki asked in an impatient tone. Izuku met his eyes.

“*Sort of*”, Izuku signed.

Katsuki sighed. Well, way to fucking go. Now he didn’t know what Icy Hot had or hadn’t told Deku about, and Deku didn’t have enough fluency in sign language to tell him.

“Whatever. We’ll just talk about it later”, he decided, still not meeting Izuku’s eyes and thus not fully seeing his reaction.

He stared out the window, instead. Nice night. No clouds in the sky, just the full moon shining brightly above them.

Deku tugged at the sleeve of his shirt, calling his attention. Once Katsuki looked back at him, he did the sign for “*when*”.

Katsuki sighed.

“When it’s not the middle of the fucking night”.

Izuku didn’t let go of his sleeve.

“What?”, Katsuki scoffed. “You can’t fucking speak. It’s not like I’m about to rant at you when you can’t say anything in return. And I know I’m probably losing a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity to just tell you whatever I want without you being able to say shit about it, but –“

Izuku’s eyes were glued on him.

Katsuki scoffed, looking away.

“What I have to say, it…”

He sighed. The moon looked beautiful.

“I want you to say something in return”.

Izuku frowned.

“So you’ll just have to fucking wait”.

Izuku's lips formed a thin line, but he nodded.

"Good", Katsuki said, and Izuku let go of his sleeve. "Has Recovery Girl checked on you today?"

Izuku nodded.

"Does she have a date for physical therapy and all that shit yet, or are you supposed to lie in bed forever?"

Izuku nodded, shifting on the bed and reaching for something on his nightstand. Rolling his eyes, Katsuki approached him and caught what he had been aiming for – a small All Might themed appointment book. Katsuki stared at Izuku, who nodded, and he opened the thing up, finding a series of appointments already scheduled there. Deku's physical therapy would start on that week, already, and his speech therapy was supposed to begin on the following one.

"Huh", Katsuki commented. "Seems you're about to get your ass out of here sooner than I expected. Any chance you'll get cleared out to be home during the holiday break?"

Izuku shrugged, looking uncertain. Katsuki huffed out a breath and closed the book up, placing it back on the top of the nightstand.

"Did you write that shit down yourself?", he asked, leaning slightly on the edge of the boy's bed and crossing his arms above his chest. Izuku smiled proudly and nodded. "Yeah, I figured. It looks like a kindergartener's fucking writing".

Izuku's smile dropped at the words, and Katsuki sighed.

You see, this is the kind of fucking comment that soul-Deku would know better than to take seriously. It took the fucker a while to realize when Katsuki was joking and when he was being actually serious, and this shitty Deku here didn't have that kind of filter.

Katsuki wished there was a way he could shove Deku's memories back into his brain without risking him blowing up to pieces. He always had the option of telling the asshole about everything that had happened using his own words, but, for some reason, that felt embarrassing, especially because Deku would retrieve his memories at some point. Katsuki would have to go through everything without altering any details, or else Deku would find out about the adulteration it later, and Katsuki would be damned if he let someone as Deku accuse him of being a liar.

So he'd have to talk about all their fucking discussions. The heart-to-hearts, the feeling-sharing, the cuddling, the getting-drunk-together, *everything*. And yeah, Katsuki might be brave as fuck, but he still wasn't brave enough to look into Deku's eyes and say out loud: "we cuddled on my bed, in my room, all night long". That demanded a whole new sort of courage that he wasn't used to and that he didn't think he could face just yet.

He didn't even know if what he felt for Deku was love yet. His brain had jumped towards that conclusion too fast, but maybe it had been just an impulse, maybe he had been wrong,

maybe he had just been conditioned to think he loved Deku because Deku loved him, or because of what Kirishima had said…

Deku's eyes shone in the moonlight. Katsuki sighed.

"I was just *joking*, asshole. Stop taking everything I say so seriously", Katsuki clarified upon Deku's miserable look, impatient, since the boy was upset over something so stupid. Deku wasn't to blame, of course – it was only expectable that he would be *even more* sensitive than usual after everything he went through, but to think that it took so little for him to make Deku so sad sent a shiver down Katsuki's spine.

He must have hurt him a lot as they grew up, right? Even when that hadn't been his intention.

Izuku frowned, looking confused. He tried to reach for the appointment book again, and Katsuki grabbed it before he could, waving it out of his reach.

"What? You plan on writing something down?"

Izuku nodded.

"Don't you think that *maybe* you should just go back to fucking sleep, since it's almost 2 a.m.?", Katsuki raised a disapproving eyebrow at him. Izuku frowned.

He waved his hands around, doing the signs for "*you*", "*wake*", and a mixture of things that Katsuki couldn't really understand.

"First of all, I didn't fucking wake you up, you did that on your own. Second of all, I have no idea what you meant by –", he crudely imitated Izuku's gestures, making them even more confusing as if to prove his point. Izuku huffed out a breath and rolled his eyes with a soft smile, gesturing at the book in Katsuki's hands.

"K-K-Ka– K-Ka – cchan, j-jus–", he attempted, which made Katsuki roll his eyes and toss him the book at once. Obviously, Izuku's reflex was still too slow, so he didn't catch it. It fell on his chest and toppled to his lap as he struggled to sit down, and, with a sigh, Katsuki walked over to the head of the bed and grabbed one of Izuku's arms, aiding him into a sitting position.

"Just so you know", Katsuki said sternly, "don't think you can cheat your way out by writing things down all the fucking time. If you're gonna learn sign language, then fucking learn sign language".

Izuku rested against the pillows that were propping him up, giving Katsuki an apologetic look. He made the signs for "*sorry*" and "*tired*", which earned another sigh from Katsuki. God, why was Deku the way he was?

"Whatever. I'll let this one slide, but just because I yelled at you earlier and I promised your mom I wouldn't yell at you while you were in the hospital", he grabbed a pen from the nightstand and handed it over to Deku, turning the lamp on. The boy squinted at the sudden brightness before giving Katsuki a confused look and opening the book.

Izuku's hands were shaking badly as he held the pen and tried to write something down. It took him a few attempts before he could properly produce the kanji he wanted, but still, as Katsuki had said, they looked like a toddler's work. That was to be expected, since Deku's body was still trying to catch up with all the horrible things it had been put through over the course of the past two months, but it still unsettled Katsuki, to see the boy so weak and fragile.

Because Deku wasn't like this. Deku never stopped talking and mumbling, he always took notes at a hundred miles per hour, he was always quick and smart and focused. Now, he could barely say a couple words at a time and it took him minutes to write down a sentence that would have only taken him seconds to produce two months before. And this only made Katsuki feel guiltier, and sadder, and angrier, because things would be so much fucking easier on him if Deku just hated him.

If Deku just hated him, then he could leave. He could turn his back on him, forget about his entire existence, and go on about his life. But having Deku love him and admire him made him feel like the feeling demanded something analogous in return, and it bound Katsuki to him – not by soul, but by heart. Because, at the end of the day, even if he managed to bring himself back to hating shitty Deku somehow, he would still owe him. Because Deku had saved his life. And he couldn't just *walk away*.

Maybe this was it. Maybe he didn't love Deku – maybe he had just convinced himself that he loved him, as a messed-up way to settle his debt with the boy. Deku had saved him, and Deku said he loved him, so the least Katsuki could do was love him back, right? The feeling he thought he felt was just a projection. Thinking back to it, his epiphany felt ludicrous – there was no way he loved Deku. There couldn't be!

~~He didn't even know what love was.~~

Deku resumed writing, looking ten times more exhausted than before, and handed the book over to Katsuki with hands that were shaking badly. Katsuki took the damn thing and brought it closer to his face so that he could read it in the dim light of the room, whereas Izuku leaned back against his pillows, looking absolutely worn out.

Kacchan, I know something happened but I can't remember and no one tells me about it. All Might said he'd tell me once I'm better and so did my mom but I don't know when that will be. Can you please tell me why you're acting so differently? I'm not complaining I just want to know. Sorry about the sign language.

Katsuki sighed heavily and threw his head back. The nosy motherfucker just didn't know how to wait, did he? He really expected Katsuki to sit down with him and make a summary of the past month in one night? While he was supposed to be fucking resting? Even if he was willing to do that for some godforsaken reason, Recovery Girl would have his head for keeping her patient up over the course of the night, so that was a big fucking no from him.

"Deku –", he started, meaning to tell Deku just that with an angry tone and an annoyance-riddled face, but as soon as he looked away from the book and towards Deku's face, he found the boy to be fast asleep, head lolled to the side, lips parted, limbs askew on his sides.

Apparently, even something as simple as writing had made him exhausted enough to pass out.

Katsuki didn't know how to feel about that.

So, instead of thinking about it, he put the book on the nightstand and removed the pen from Deku's limp hand in order to place it there too. Then, he carefully removed one of the pillows behind Deku so that his body would go back into a horizontal position and tucked him in.

He stared at Deku's sleeping face, holding the spare pillow beneath one arm. He looked stupid like that. Too thin, too green, too dumb. There was drool already coming out from the corner of his mouth. Gross. No way Katsuki could love him, ever. If anything, he was probably right to despise him. Stupid fucking Deku.

Katsuki crouched down in front of the nightstand in order to put the spare pillow away, pulling the large bottom drawer open. However, there was no space for the pillow there, which Katsuki found suspicious.

The drawer was full of books. He had seen one of the nurses retrieving and putting pillows away in that very drawer a hundred times over. As far as he knew, no one kept any fucking books in there.

Katsuki grabbed one of them up, staring at the cover.

Introduction to Japanese Sign Language.

He picked another one up, then another. *Basic Sign Language. My friend is hard of hearing – a guide to support people with hearing disabilities. Sign Language for Kids. Sign Language for Dummies. Sign Language 101.*

Yeah, fuck, ok. Something was definitely bubbling up at his chest at this, and he suppressed the urge to toss the entire fucking drawer out the window. What the *fuck*.

He shoved the books back into the drawer, closed it (not as silently as he had intended, but Deku didn't stir), got to his feet, and awkwardly held the pillow in his hands, not knowing what to do with it. He hated how tight his chest felt.

On the bed, Deku was still fast asleep. So the fucker had really gone and convinced someone to bring him books on sign language, right? Just so that he could talk to Katsuki. Just so that… God damn it. His chest felt warm at that. Warm, and filled with all sorts of mixed-up feelings that he didn't want to have to deal with. And Katsuki hated the fact that he could no longer fucking deny the fact that he… He…

He shoved the pillow on the spare visitor's chair at the corner of the room, made sure Deku's arms weren't exposed to the chilly wind of the night, and stormed the hell out of there.

He marched his way to Kirishima's bedroom with the fury of an army and slammed his fist on the door, not caring it was the middle of the night.

The boy opened the door with wide eyes and bed-hair, so suddenly and unexpectedly that Katsuki almost knocked his fist against his face due to the abrupt absence of the wooden surface. Kirishima rubbed the sleep from his eyes and stared at Katsuki with confusion and concern, looking like he was still too half-asleep to make sense of what was happening.

"Bakugou, what –?", he mumbled, frowning, to which Katsuki simply pushed him into the room, closed the door behind them, and yelled:

"You were fucking right, are you glad, now, Shitty Hair?!"

Kirishima stared at him, squinting.

"*What*?"

"You were fucking *right*", Katsuki accused, pointing a shaking finger at him.

"About what, man? It's – It's almost 3 a.m. –"

"You were right about being wrong".

Kirishima stared at him through squinted eyes in the darkness.

"Wha–"

"About Deku. And me", Katsuki panted, his hands turned into fists beside him. "You said you were wrong. And you were. And I'm sorry I was an asshole to you in the past days, but I fucking needed someone to watch my back and you fucking *walked out* on me".

Kirishima looked shocked.

"Bakugou – D-Dude, I –"

"Spare me, Shitty Hair".

"No", Kirishima shook his head, walking over to him. "No, man, dude, seriously. I'd – I'd never walk out on you. Ok? That wasn't what I meant by that. At all. I just – I wanted you to take care of yourself, man".

"I fucking am".

"No, you're not".

“Fuck off, Kirishima”.

“Dude, it’s 3 a.m. and you were just screaming in the middle of the hall. You’re clearly not ok”.

“I’m fucking fine”, Katsuki growled aggressively past the knot in his throat.

“Hey. Hey man”, Kirishima stretched his arms to the side. “Come here”.

“Like hell I will”.

“Come on, bro”, Kirishima enveloped him in a hug. “See? That’s better”.

“Don’t fucking talk to me like I’m some sort of fucking baby”, Katsuki’s voice sounded muffled against Kirishima’s shoulder, but he allowed himself to be hugged.

“I’m not, man. You just looked like you needed a hug”.

They stayed like that for a while until the physical contact became too much and Katsuki pushed Kirishima away. The boy complied, breaking the hug as soon as he sensed Katsuki’s resistance, and he sat at the edge of his own unmade bed, whereas Katsuki remained on his feet.

“You wanna talk about what happened?”

“I don’t know what the fuck you mean”.

“Well, clearly something happened for you to come barging into my room at this hour”.

“I didn’t *barge* –“

“Ok, ok, ok, bad choice of words! But I mean – Y-You can talk, man. About whatever you want. Ok? I’m not walking out on you, dude, you’re my best friend. So, anything you want to tell me about, you can tell me, all right?”

Katsuki stared at him.

“But… If – If you don’t wanna talk, that’s cool too”.

Katsuki thought for a moment.

“I don’t want to talk about it”.

“Sure, uh. Ok. Is there – Is there anything I can do to help, then?”

Katsuki bowed his head, impatient. His heart was still racing and he felt like punching a hole through the wall. It took all his self-control not to do so.

“Can we just go fucking back to the way things used to be?”, Katsuki growled, hating how pathetic he sounded. “And I don’t fucking mean the sparring, Kirishima, it’s just –“

He shook his head, blinking past the hateful wetness in his eyes. He tried to convince himself those were angry tears, tears that had nothing to do with Deku and his lack of memory and the fact that, until he got his quirk and his memories back, Katsuki would be all alone.

“Right now, you’re the only one who fucking gets me”, Katsuki admitted.

Kirishima stood up, walking over to Katsuki with a sad look on his face.

“Sure, man. I mean – whatever you need”, Kirishima nodded at him, offering him a tiny smile.

Katsuki scowled at him, shrugging away from the touch.

“Oh, fuck off”.

“What?!”

“Don’t look so fucking smug about it!”

“But Bakubro, it’s our first make-up session!”

“We didn’t make up for anything, douchebag!”

“Yes, we did! For our lost friendship!”

“It wasn’t lost!”

“Well, you’re the one who –“

“Don’t you fucking *dare*”.

“Ok, ok! I’ll stop! I was just joking!”, he chuckled. “But really, man, you look like you could use a friend”.

“The fuck do you think I’m here for? You’re my *best* friend”.

Kirishima’s eyes became instantly filled with tears and he covered his mouth with both hands, shocked. Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“… *Bro*”, he whispered, voice thick with emotion. Katsuki grunted.

“*Stop that*, it’s not like you didn’t know that already!”, he protested.

“I did, but… It was more of an unspoken thing, you know, it wasn’t official, man, I… Wow, I don’t know… I don’t know what to say…”, Kirishima said dramatically.

“Then don’t say anything, *god*”, Katsuki sighed, and if he rolled his eyes any harder, they’d spot his brain.

“Well, now that we’re officially best friends –“

“Kirishima –“

“Do I get to make one best friend demand?”

Katsuki scowled at him.

“What the hell are you talking about?”

“You know, I get to make a demand, you get to make a demand, it’s the best friend demand!”

“Tch. I never heard of this shit before”.

“That’s probably because I just invented it”.

“I’m fucking leaving”, he immediately turned towards the door.

“No, wait! I was being serious, though, man, I do –“, Katsuki stopped on his tracks to look at Kirishima over his shoulder. “I do want to ask you for something”.

Katsuki turned on his heels and squinted at his friend.

“Spit it”, Katsuki said.

“Well, uh, I mean – maybe try to answer your texts more often? I’ve been reaching out to you like crazy to talk about our, uh, fight, or whatever you want to call that, but you never answered and that got me worried. And then out of nowhere you just start sitting with us again, and I was pretty confused, because I wanted to give you space but I was also worried and you weren’t texting me back, so… You know…?”

Really? *That* was Kirishima’s demand? Katsuki had been expecting something astronomic, not a demand as simple as ‘check your messages’.

“*Fine*”, Katsuki responded simply, as if it was no big deal – which it wasn’t.

“You got it, man”, Kirishima smiled widely at him.

“Hm. Is that all?”

“Uh… You tell me, man. You want to talk about that Midoriya thing or what? You still haven’t told me about the F-word –“

“Good fucking night, Shitty Hair”.

“No, Bakubro, wait, nooo!”, Kirishima wailed as Katsuki walked out of his room and slammed the door behind him.

From: Bakugou

Send me your best emo music

From: Ears

What the hell

From: Ears

Do you even know what time it is?

From: Bakugou

Don’t act like you weren’t awake. You replied way too fast for someone who was asleep

From: Ears

I never said I was asleep, just asked you about the time.

From: Ears

But anyway, here’s the playlist

From: Bakugou

What the fuck

From: Bakugou

Does your quirk involve making playlists superfast or some shit?

From: Ears

I had that ready, dumbass

From: Ears

I have a playlist for everyone in Class 1-A

From: Bakugou

That’s fucking cheesy

From: Ears

Weren’t you supposed to be asleep? It’s past 8 p.m. already ^-^

From: Bakugou

Oh, go fuck yourself

From: Ears

Is the baby grumpy because he stayed up past his curfew? :cc

From: Bakugou

You got some balls don't you shitty ears??? You keep mocking me about the sleep time thing and ill shove those jack of yours in your damn nostrils

From: Ears

I see the anger management is going well huh

From: Bakugou

GET READY TO THROW HANDS AT DAWN

From: Ears

Don't caps lock me

From: Ears

And you're welcome for the playlist

From: Ears

Let me know what you think of it later

From: Bakugou

Yeah whatever

From: Shitty Hair

Hey there best friend

From: Best Friend

Will you cry if I tell you that's embarrassing

From: Shitty Hair

:-(

From: Shitty Hair

Sort of :-(

From: Best Friend

Fine then I won't tell you

From: Shitty Hair

D-:

From: Shitty Hair

Well… but I am glad we got everything sorted out, tho

From: Best Friend

I know, shitty hair. I am too

From: Shitty Hair

And sorry if I'm too nosy sometimes

From: Shitty Hair

You don't need to talk about certain stuff if it makes you uncomfortable

From: Shitty Hair

Just… you know

From: Shitty Hair

Make an effort? To reply more often? And maybe try to talk more about stuff?

From: Best Friend

Like I'm doing right now?

From: Best Friend

I'll talk when I'm ready to talk

From: Shitty Hair

Yeah, pretty much like rn!

From: Shitty Hair

And it's fine, man, just take your time. You can talk when you're ready ok? I'll always be here for u!

From: Best Friend

Cheesy

From: Shitty Hair

:-/

From: Best Friend

I'm just teasing you, dipshit.

From: Best Friend

You fell asleep didn't you

From: Best Friend

Typical

From: Best Friend

Anyway. Sorry for being an asshole to you.

From: Best Friend

Also, can this count as an official apology for all the times I'll be an asshole to you in the future? I hate repeating my fucking self, this way it's easier

From: Best Friend

I'll take your silence as a yes

From: Bakugou

It was ok

From: Ears

Don’t act like you didn’t love it

From: Bakugou

Well… It surpassed my expectations

From: Ears

Quit the BS

From: Bakugou

Fine, it was pretty good. How did you figure out exactly what fucking songs I’d like? That’s creepy.

From: Ears

I’ve got an ear for that ^-^

From: Bakugou

Yikes.

From: Ears

How did you even listen to it, though? I hope you didn’t blast the death metal songs I put in the playlist in the middle of the boy’s dorm at 3 a.m., Bakugou

From: Bakugou

I still have one good ear, dipshit

From: Ears

I know, but isn’t it better to preserve it?! Wearing earphones is bad for your ear’s health

From: Bakugou

Shouldn’t you advocate earphones, since you’re literally fucking called earphone girl??

From: Bakugou

But yeah, I’m taking good care of my other ear now, which is why I just blasted the playlist at top volume in the middle of the boy’s dorm instead of using earphones like a normal human being

From: Ears

BAKUGOU

From: Bakugou

Just kidding

From: Ears

Oh my god

From: Bakugou

Go to sleep, Ears. Thanks for the playlist

From: Ears

No big deal. I actually enjoy making this sort of stuff

From: Bakugou

Weirdo

From: Ears

Shut up

Chapter End Notes

Bakugrowth

Also... I originally said this was going to be 19 chapters long, but I just upped it to 20! So... Three more chapters ahead of us? It's been such a long run!

Also also, I think Jirou and Bakugou would have such a snarky friendship if they were closer to each other, idk. Let me dream.

Oh! An important note. I am not fluent in sign language (I just had some very basic classes at uni and they were all in Portuguese, which is my native language), so if anything is off or weird or inaccurate about the way I wrote it, please let me know and I'll fix it! I did some research and used some websites for support, but they were either in Portuguese or in English, which are probably different from Japanese Sign Language. If you find any mistakes or problematic points in the way I portrayed sign language and/or hard of hearing characters, let me know and I'll do my best to fix it!

As always, thanks for reading, guys. You all are the best and you live in my heart <3

Chapter 18: Thoughts, Words, Deeds

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Katsuki woke up with a streak of sunlight falling upon his eyes.

He groaned and sighed with profound irritation, wondering yet fucking again why he hadn't gotten rid of his damn curtains already if they sucked so badly at doing their one job. Instead of blowing the damn things to hell like he wanted to, he turned on the bed so that he was lying on his belly and stretched in a cat-like way, arms above his head and back arching off the mattress gracefully. A small, pleased whimper escaped his lips as the pressure on his back faded, and, with another sigh, he sat up.

He stretched his shoulders, then his arms, then he stood up and stretched his legs as well. He didn't bother checking the time as he bent over his studying desk and tidied the fucking curtains until they were shut all the way through, blocking any possible streaks of unwanted sunlight from entering the room. His hand lingered on the material for a few moments too long, a feral, childish urge to be petty and destroy the shitty thing that had caused him to rouse from sleep lingering at the back of his brain.

Katsuki had complained to his therapist over and over again about how that "T.H.I.N.K." strategy was fucking stupid and, in his words, "kindergartener stuff". He always felt like a stupid kid whenever he stopped to think before he opened his mouth: *is it True? Is it Helpful? Is it Inspiring? Is it Necessary? Is it Kind?,* and thus using that method only made him feel angrier than he had started off. Doctor Matsuo had promised to think of something else that could aid him in behaving more nicely without eventually turning him into a rage gremlin, which resulted on a new mantra he needed to work on remembering.

Good thoughts, good words, good deeds. That was what she insisted he should commit to, and even though he knew Doctor Matsuo had stolen that from somewhere – she had commented it was some sort of dogma in a specific religion or whatever, not that he ever really cared about that sort of thing –, she insisted he should take the words to heart with despite his religion or beliefs.

What she probably meant was: "You should try and focus on having a more positive outlook in life, behaving properly, and stop being so negative all the time, since good actions result on good things", but all Katsuki heard was: "Stop having such vicious thoughts about murder every time a small inconvenience fucking occurs, and try your best to solve things rationally instead of losing it like a maniac all the goddamn time, you fucktwat".

Personally, Katsuki thought this was all a bunch of bullshit – if thinking positively ever resulted on miraculously good things, then there would be no fucking homeless, starving, dying people around the world. If someone wants something good to happen, they need to take fucking agency and do it themselves; not lie around thinking of flowery gardens and bunnies or whatever.

As for the good deeds – he wanted to be a fucking hero. It was a *basic requirement* for him to do good things, even if he *felt* like blowing half of the world up most of the time.

Still, he had to admit that, despite everything, Doctor Matsuo was doing a pretty decent job at helping him manage his anger. He knew he was a difficult patient, and he was not accidentally so, but he was also aware that he was succeeding more often at having a bit extra patience before he lost his cool. He was hot-headed by nature, and he didn't think that would ever fully change, but even the douchebags he called *friends* were starting to notice his change in behavior. He hadn't *changed*, per say, but he was definitely different. Less… *Explosive*, in a way. Which was fucking ironic.

Because of this, Katsuki figured that following her advice on this mantra thing couldn't really hurt, especially since he had just wasted a fuckton of his time wondering whether or not he should adopt the mantra because of something as stupid and meaningless as his fucking *curtains*.

Instead of blowing the fucking useless curtains to hell like they deserved to, Katsuki let go of them after closing them off. It didn't matter that he accidentally left hand-shaped scorched prints on the surface, or that he felt stupid about overthinking this situation in the first place.

He'd been feeling a lot like that, recently. *Stupid.* It felt like some level of betrayal to his own self to try and keep his cool all the time. He was Bakugou fucking *Katsuki*. If there was something he was known for, it was for having a short temper. Something as ridiculous as *not yelling at his curtains* felt like he was losing himself, or worse – like he was allowing himself to be shaped and tamed.

Yes. *That* was the word. He felt like he was allowing himself to be *tamed*, and he fucking hated it.

But… he also knew he didn't have much of a choice on this matter. It was either learning how to control his anger – or rather, allowing his anger to be controlled – or getting kicked out of school and throwing everything he's ever dreamed of in the damn trash.

Deep down, the selfish, still bitter part of himself wanted to blame Deku for all those bad feelings he was being forced to deal with. The helplessness, the frustration, the sensation of being *tamed* and losing himself… If the asshole hadn't taken the blow in his place, if the asshole hadn't spent a month living with Katsuki 24/7, then he'd still be able to have his angry fits without being held accountable for them. People had complained about his behavior before, sure, he had heard complains all his life, but *no one* had ever threatened to expel him. It was only after – and because of – the Deku-situation that this became an actual, tangible risk.

Katsuki sighed, sounding tired even though he had just woken up. He knew that, despite his bitterness and his desire to shove the blame on Deku, this was bound to happen in one way or another. He was bound to reach a point of his life where he would be forced to grow the hell up, to stop being so explosive about every little thing, and to take responsibility for the shit he did while he acted with a hot head.

(He only wished Deku hadn't almost died in the fucking process for him to realize all that).

Whenever Katsuki looked for heroes in the media, he never found anyone like him. Ambitious ones? Definitely. Arrogant ones? More often than not. Reckless ones? There were some, yes. But short-fused? Hot-headed? *Ill-tempered*? Katsuki couldn't recall any. And yeah, he spent most of his life telling himself that he would be the first one, but *now* he knew better than to try and do that. More specifically, he knew better than to risk his luck – the fact that Aizawa sensei, a teacher who was famous for kicking students out at any given opportunity, had decided to give *Katsuki*, a problem-student, another chance to prove himself, was an opportunity he wasn't about to throw in the trash over something as petty and meaningless as his ego.

And yeah, Katsuki had reached a point in his life where he referred to his own ego as petty and meaningless. And it *was*, in the face of everything that had happened. His fucking ego was *dull* when compared to Deku almost dying because he tried to save him. When compared to all the major events that had changed his life and his own self-perception in the past months. And this was fucking ironic, because once upon a time, ego had been *everything* for him. Now, it was just a faraway thought, half-forgotten and buried under a lot of more urgent issues he had to uncover.

He wasn't sure how he felt about that, not really.

His ego had cost him his hearing. His ego had ruined his relationship with Deku for over a decade. His ego had almost kicked him out of the fucking school he had always dreamed of entering. His ego was also his hubris. And he was done letting it rule over him.

He couldn't let it be his downfall. Not again, not anymore. He would never be a good hero if he kept allowing himself to be reigned by his pride.

He had a lot to think about, a lot to figure out, and not much disposition to do that. Everyone told him that things would get better with due time, but from Katsuki's point of view, time only made things worse. Extra time caused him to think about the shit that had happened, and the consequences of that. Extra time caused him to think about shitty Deku, and the state he was in, and his amnesia, and his damn quirk.

If anything, Katsuki hated all the extra time he had. He'd much rather occupy his busy brain with other thoughts; thoughts that didn't make him almost lose control and feel like punching a hole through the fucking wall.

Now that his room was enveloped in darkness again, he wasted no time in getting to the floor and starting his morning workout routine. As he exercised, he did his best to prevent his mind from wandering at places he didn't want to tread in, like it had been doing ever since he rose from sleep, and instead focused on his list of tasks he had for that day.

Work out. Take a shower. Do his homework for Monday. Study for his Sign Language exam that was coming up. Train with All Might after lunch. Then he would have the whole afternoon free for himself. Not that he had much to do with the damn *free time*, anyway.

He figured he could always use the spare time of the well-deserved weekend break to study some more and make sure he kept himself top of his class. Even though he had managed to pull himself back to his feet in the terms of studying and keeping up with his class, he could

still put some more effort into that. He probably should, even. Becoming number one didn't come without hard work.

But, as much as he tried to avert his thoughts from the idea that kept nagging at his brain, as much as he tried to pretend that he *wouldn't do that*, he knew, for whatever reason he couldn't really figure out yet, *exactly* what he would end up doing with his free fucking time.

Yeah. Katsuki started to do his pushups harder, faster, until he was panting and sweating, his room filled with the sweet, thick scent of nitroglycerin.

Once he was done with his morning workout session, he got to his feet and took his clothes off, dropping them on a heap next to his bed. Heading to the bathroom, he took a long, hot shower, hot enough to fill the bathroom with steam and to soothe his tired, aching muscles. And, as the hot water fell on his shoulders and ran down his back and arms, Katsuki closed his eyes, trying his best not to let the image of green eyes and freckled cheeks overwhelm his thoughts ~~*again*~~.

No such luck.

He left the bathroom feeling angrier than he had entered, and he decided to blame his increasingly sour mood on the fact that he had been so abruptly woken up with no warning. Goddamn his useless curtains to hell.

(It was easier to blame the curtains than to admit to certain things, even if he was undeniably getting better at the whole admitting-stuff-to-himself thing. It was still a work in progress).

When he opened his laptop in order to get to the fucking studying-part of his day, hair still dripping wet and making the back of his shirt moist, he did so with a bit more force than he had intended – probably a result of his irritation. Thankfully, the device wasn't harmed, and Katsuki dropped heavily on his rolling chair after putting some comfortable clothes on, grabbing his notebook and gritting his teeth in anticipation already.

Good thoughts, good deeds, or whatever bullshit that woman wanted him to fucking apply to his routine. She had told him not to think of it as a dogma, but as an advice. Something that would make his life easier and more productive. Something that would make his *hero career* easier and more productive. His relationships, his interactions, his feelings more productive. Something that would also prevent him from blowing his laptop, his notebook, and his entire studying desk up.

Tch.

He finished his homework faster than he had expected, but wasn't exactly surprised by it. The truth was: ever since Deku woke up after the two months of hell, Katsuki finally found himself able to *focus* for fucking once and managed to get himself back on top of his class without breaking a sweat. He should probably thank Kirishima for the notes he lent him when he was too distracted or worried to focus in the lectures, and he should probably thank Yaoyorozu for letting Kirishima steal her notes for him.

(He wouldn't actually thank them, though. It was more of a figure of speech, even though he could almost hear Deku's voice telling him that *Kacchan, there's nothing wrong with being nice to people!*)

Ugh. Yikes. Deku and Doctor Matsuo were way too similar, sometimes.

Katsuki had been unfocused as hell during the month after Deku's soul returned to his body and he remained in a coma. He wasn't really to blame for that, and he hated to even think about how easily he'd been thrown off his feet. Because *really*? All it took to break him off his years-long, unfaltering concentration and focus on his education was fucking *Deku*, of all things?

Being the best and being a hero were the only two things that had ever mattered to Katsuki in his life – the only two priorities he was *always* focused on, no matter what happened. And now... Everything felt like it had been turned upside down. The rug had been pulled from beneath his feet, and his perspective had changed from the way he lopsided. He couldn't tell right from wrong anymore.

The last think Katsuki knew, much to his dismay, was how he felt about all this. He had come to terms with the fact that he no longer wanted shitty Deku to die miserably in a hole like he had wished for throughout their entire lives – merely the *thought* of that made him shiver, memories of dead eyes and the constant, high-pitched noise of a flatlining heart monitor erupting in his thoughts –, and he was currently in the process of coming to terms with the fact that he kind of *liked* Deku, and cared about him, and…

Well.

That other thing he didn't like thinking about, because it couldn't be true.

He couldn't come to *love* a person he had always hated so fast, could he? That was fucking ridiculous. No one could come to love another person so fast. He couldn't.

(~~He didn't even know what love was~~).

Everything about his behavior felt unhinged – going to Kirishima, going to Deku's room in the middle of the fucking night, and god, what the hell had he been thinking? He almost spilled everything to Kirishima's ears that night, everything about those confusing feelings that he thought he had figured out, only for him to deconstruct on the following moment. And the only reason he didn't spill his fucking guts to Kirishima was because his best friend was a fucking idiot with no brain-to-mouth filter and his stupidity made Katsuki come to his senses before he said something he would regret.

Because he didn't love Deku. *Deku* was the one who loved him. He was just projecting shit. Right? He liked Deku and he cared about him now, even though his past self would probably spontaneously combust if he ever admitted that aloud. He finally felt guilty for all the fucked-up stuff he had done and said throughout the years, even though he was still a firm believer of the fact that he couldn't change the fucking past and thus shouldn't break a sweat over it. But he didn't *love* Deku. That was stupid. That was fucking *stupid*.

Katsuki sighed. Even after all this time, it was still hard from him to totally understand and accept how much Deku had started to affect him these past months.

Because, apparently, spending an entire month with Deku and developing an emotional, empathic, personal, intimate, literal soul bond with him, only to watch him disappear in front of his eyes and then flatline on a damn hospital bed, was something that no one could come out of without being a little shaken. And Katsuki had never been the type of person to be ‘a little shaken’ by any fucking thing, but apparently, he was, now.

He'd been thinking a lot about that, recently. He hadn’t told Doctor Matsuo about One For All, of course – that was a secret he was supposed to take to his grave, if not for All Might’s sake, then for Deku’s –, but he had mentioned his creepy dreams of Deku calling after him and some other stuff that had been bothering him – such as Deku being a bony bastard now, and Deku needing help to do everything, and Deku needing speech therapy, and Deku’s existence in general. For someone who was officially required to attend therapy due to his temper, Katsuki spent a whole lot of time talking about shitty Deku and not enough time complaining about his anger.

But it was all connected, in a way. Deku has been the main source of his anger since the beginning of fucking times, right? It was only right Katsuki tried to solve his anger issue by focusing on the root of his problem.

He closed his notebook off with a vengeance and decided to start studying for his Sign Language test. He was wasting *way* too much fucking time thinking about Deku. In fact, now that he put some thought into it, he decided to go plus ultra on that shit and fucking get himself leveled up already. He was done attending classes with fucking newbies and extras that were so far below him. He was fairly sure he had every and all ability to get ahead of his level; maybe he could even take some extra presential classes in order to skip levels or something.

This felt like staying true to himself in a way – yeah, ok, so maybe he sort of cared about shitty Deku now, but, at least, if he was still the best of the best despite that, he wouldn’t feel so bad about this whole shitshow.

Despite the curtains and the green eyes that wouldn’t leave his head unless he put a special effort on *not* thinking about, he supposed he was having a fairly good morning. Not much had changed in his routine in the past few weeks – Deku had started the damn physical therapy a while ago, which meant he was mostly exhausted whenever Katsuki visited at night, and, since he had also started speech therapy, he was getting better at forming some sentences and words more proficiently.

As the days passed by, Deku’s need for sign language grew smaller and smaller, and more often than not Katsuki caught him chatting excitedly with a nurse or with Todoroki. His speech rate was definitely slower than it used to be, but, if Katsuki knew anything about this stubborn brat, was that he’d manage to throw himself back into rambling non-stop as soon as he had the chance.

Funnily enough, Deku still used sign language whenever Katsuki was there, though. He had gotten better at it, too – probably an effect of the physical therapy, which improved his

coordination. But, if Katsuki was being honest, it kind of bothered him a little that Deku seemed willing to babble and rant at all the other fuckers who went there to visit him, but not at Katsuki.

And yeah, ok, if Katsuki could admit that he fucking missed Deku's *rambling*, of all the godforsaken things in the world, then he was past the point of pretending he didn't actually care for the shitty nerd.

What a fucking mess.

He should probably tell Deku about it, though. *Not* about the caring-for-him part, he'd die before he did that, but about the sign language thing. If there was one thing he had learned over the course of the month he spent with Deku's shitty ghost clinging to his back, was that when it came to this fucker, Katsuki was better off saying stuff out loud than hoping for Deku to just fucking guess what he was feeling and thinking.

Deku was too much of an oblivious idiot to get hints, no matter how fucking obvious they were, and unless Katsuki went to his face and said "why the fuck do you talk to everyone around here but only use fucking sign language with me you idiot?!", Deku would never understand that this was the reason for his sour moods when he visited.

But despite his obvious improving, Deku was still weak. Not as weak as he had been when he first woke up, that was for sure, but still... Too bony and tired for Katsuki's liking. And now that he was actually working on getting better, instead of just lying around in bed uselessly all day long, Katsuki couldn't help but to notice how tired he looked. Bone-deep tired, as if a simple session of stretching his arms and legs around with a nurse's help took all his energy from him. If Deku could barely keep his eyes open when Katsuki visited him after dinner, how the *fuck* was he supposed to train with All Might to regain his muscular mass? How the fuck was he supposed to go back to the way he used to be?

How the fuck was he supposed to take One For All back?

Katsuki could almost hear Doctor Matsuo's voice scolding him for putting the cart before the horse, and deep down he knew that Deku's situation was way too complicated and things wouldn't go back to normal overnight. Recovery took time, especially in a case as delicate as Deku's – he'd spent an entire month with no soul in his body. *Obviously,* it would take him time to get back in shape.

But, deep down, and rather selfishly if he thought about it, Katsuki couldn't help but to wish there was a way to make the boy recover faster – because the faster Deku got better, the faster Katsuki could get rid of that unwanted power that was coursing through his veins.

Because he could feel it, now that he's had it for a while. Every time he trained with Kirishima or Todoroki; hell, every time he trained with All Might and had to use a bit more force than expected, he felt it – the buzz, the tingle at the tip of his fingers, the energy coursing through his muscles and his bones and his very core. One For All was inside him, ready to activate, ready to surface should Katsuki only set his self-control aside for one moment and allow that tremendous power to overtake him.

But he wouldn't. He *couldn't*. That wasn't his power to use; he wasn't borrowing it – he was just storing it, keeping it safe, so that it could be properly returned to Deku once his body was healthy enough to sustain it.

Once he was healthy enough to recover his memories.

Seeing Deku die, it had – it had done things to Katsuki. He hated the word "traumatized", so he would settle for "a little shaken" for the time being. Still, he reached the conclusion, after a few days of introspection and annoyance, that what fucked him up the most about this whole story wasn't just seeing Deku die. It was seeing Deku die three fucking times.

This was something Katsuki couldn't simply pretend hadn't affected him, no matter how much he hated the thought of even being affected in the first place. Because he *had* lost Deku three times now, hadn't he? First, when the villain attacked them and he had to see Deku's lifeless body lie atop him, beside him, inert and limp on the ground, eyes open and green and unseeing in a way that still haunted his nightmares to this day.

Deku, wake the fuck up. I'm serious, you asshole. Get up. Wake up. Come on. Wake up. You goddamn piece of shit, wake the hell up!

Is this the heir to All Might's power?

Second, when he promised Deku he had him, he fucking *had* him, and then Deku slipped through his fingers and disappeared beneath him like sand, despite Katsuki's promise, despite Katsuki's best attempts.

What did I fucking tell you? I'm not letting go, Deku. I've fucking got you. Ok? I've got you, just – just calm the hell down. I'm not letting go. I'm here. I've got you.

Don't you fucking trust me, shitty nerd? Didn't I just tell you I'm not letting go?

Third, when Deku's heart stopped beating right in front of him, which was probably the worst time of all. Because that was the fucking closest he actually got to losing Deku – he had actually *died* for a moment. His heart had stopped beating; he had stopped breathing. He had been dead. For a fucking minute, he had been dead. And he could have stayed that way. He could have actually died, gone forever, lost for good, and there would have been nothing Katsuki could have done about it. And he couldn't even remember what his last words to Deku had been – probably a promise he couldn't keep, or something that would never be able to represent everything he wanted to say.

And Katsuki – yeah, Katsuki was having a bit of a hard time coping with that.

It all felt a bit too ironical, really. Maybe the universe was taking a piss at him, because he couldn't help but to feel like watching Deku die was becoming a regular event in his life, and he didn't know what he would do if he lost the nerd a fourth time.

Was that his punishment for telling the asshole to kill himself back when he was still a rude, insensitive brat? Having to watch him die over and over again like some sort of messed up, sadistic joke? Being forced to deal with the loss, and the pain, and the guilt that only seemed

to grow bigger and bigger inside him with each passing day? The guilt he hated with all his being, because he had never felt it before, and that still ate up his insides every time he remembered Deku's dead eyes and pleading calls of his name?

What the *fuck* would it take for Katsuki to make up for all that shit? What the fuck would it take for Katsuki to stop feeling that way?

Deku had already forgiven him. Right? He had said so himself, before they went to the sewers, during their last argument. He had said that he had forgiven Katsuki for everything, so why the *fuck* was he still so shaken by that whole take-a-swan-dive-off-the-roof-of-the-building shit? What was in the past was in the past. No amount of therapy and guilt-inducing sessions would change his mind about that. He *couldn't* change the things he'd done and said. They were done. There was no way to alter it, or to made it so that it had never happened.

But, for the first time in his life, and much for his surprise... Katsuki wished he could.

Because so far, this had been his approach when it came to this situation: it's in the past and it can't be changed, so *get fucking over it.* He had even told Deku so, himself. He was aware that his words had been harsh and cruel and fucked up, but he had already said them. It was already done. There was nothing he could do about that. And so he hadn't bothered.

But now, he effectively *wished* there was something he could do about them, no matter how stupid and weak that made him feel. And though he couldn't exactly travel back in time and erase his words and actions, what he *could* do – and was trying to do – was to be better and not do that sort of shit anymore.

Like Deku had told him he should do. Like Deku had not only encouraged, but also *taught* him to do.

Then why couldn't he stop thinking about that?

It quite honestly pissed him off. Maybe it was the fact that Deku didn't really remember Katsuki's previous apology, or any of their conversations, or any of their arguments, or any of their resolutions. And Katsuki didn't even know how to deal with Deku like that.

Because he *would* remember everything at some point, so there was no reason to pretend nothing had happened between them, or nothing had changed between them. There was no point in pretending that they hadn't cuddled, or gotten drunk together, or watched childhood videos together, or discussed their feelings together, because, no matter how much Katsuki dreaded that moment and how much he'd rather bury all that, Deku *would* remember everything at some point. When he got One For All back. And it would be fucking *embarrassing*.

But also... relieving.

Relieving because now, with this fucking amnesiac Deku, Katsuki had to be fucking careful. It wasn't the asshole's fault he didn't remember shit, and Katsuki had become mature enough to acknowledge and respect that at this point. Shoving the blame on Deku would get them nowhere, and it would probably only make everything about this already shitty situation

worse. But his major problem at that moment was the knowledge that Deku would regain his memories *later*, added to the knowledge that Deku didn't have his memories *now*.

It would all be so much fucking easier if Katsuki knew for sure that Deku would never remember anything about the shitshow that had taken place during that soul-month. This way, Katsuki could be childish and pretend nothing had happened, or he could be reasonable and try to start things over with Deku, now that he better understood how the boy felt and how he thought. Either way, he wouldn't be bound by circumstance – he would be able to build something new with Deku from scratch without having to rely on the nerd's lost memories.

But like this? He had no way out. He was fucking *cornered*. He couldn't go back to treating Deku like shit, because when he eventually regained his memories, he would be upset and deem Katsuki an asshole for throwing all their growth in the trash (and he wouldn't be wrong in doing so). He also couldn't resort to treating *this* Deku the same way he used to treat *soul*-Deku, because his behavior would be a lot more friendly and more intimate than the amnesiac Deku was used to, and it was bound to freak him the hell out.

Katsuki had no way out but to be not-too-rude and not-too-nice, since both options would either make Deku upset or freak him the fuck out. What he needed to do was find the perfect balance between asshole and tender, douchebag and nice guy, which was fucking *hard* and only increased his wish that Deku just got better enough to regain his fucking memories already. Katsuki could barely bring himself to a fully-nice person, let alone a half-nice person.

Plus, sometimes, Katsuki still had trouble remembering that Deku's memories were temporarily gone. Sometimes, he would mention things, things he had talked about with soul-Deku, but not with corporeal Deku. On worse times, he would act around amnesiac-Deku in the way he was used to acting around soul-Deku – expecting him to understand he wasn't being serious, or entering a sort of banter that the boy's soul version had grown used to interpreting, or even going as far as ruffling his hair or shoving him playfully. And the look of utter confusion that would overtake his green eyes sent fury and anger sparkling in Katsuki's heart because it wasn't *fair.*

It wasn't fair that Deku got to forget. It wasn't fair that Katsuki was the one plagued with nightmares of dead eyes and sobbing pleas. It wasn't fair that Katsuki was the one who had to deal with all the fucking "trauma" when all Deku did was fucking forget about everything and stare at him with those confused wide eyes as if he was the one who was acting wrong.

It wasn't fair that they had sorted all their shit out only for Deku to forget about all that. It wasn't fair that they had learned so much about each other, that they had set their differences aside, only for Deku's mind to go blank. It wasn't fair that Katsuki had gone through all that trouble – feeling new things, and coming to understand his feelings, and trying to understand Deku better – only for Deku to look at him as if he was still nothing more than his childhood *fucking* bully.

It pissed Katsuki off. It really did. Because, now, when he looked at Deku's stupid bony ass lying in bed, looking all fragile and weak because of *him,* Katsuki felt like giving him a hug. He felt like putting his fucking carefully crafted walls down and allowing the boy to touch him, to give him that physical comfort that Katsuki had longed for during all his life without

ever realizing it. He felt like allowing Deku to fix his touch-starvation, he felt like playing with his stupid green curls, he felt like playfully shoving him around like he did to Kirishima, he felt like ruffling his hair, he felt like engaging on that playful banter that soul-Deku had learned how to interpret, that soul-Deku knew better than to take to heart, and that soul-Deku wouldn't look so confused and scared about.

But when he did that to *this* Deku, who had no memory of their time together, who had no memory of drinking games and arguments in bathroom stalls and hugging sessions, all he received in return was a look that was either horrified, confused, afraid, or hurt. And Katsuki fucking *hated* it.

It felt like he had finally taken that one final step forward towards the finishing line of victory after years of emotional constipation, only to be held back from climbing up to the podium.

And there was nothing he could fucking do but wait, because it was only a matter of time before recognition sparkled in those green eyes again. But, until it did, he would have to live with the knowledge that he had built something with Deku – not quite a friendship, but something more... specific – something that he could only have with Deku and no one else, something that belonged only to the two of them. Something that took a lifetime of knowing each other to achieve. And something that Deku didn't remember.

And he would have to wait.

Yeah, in summary, Katsuki had been moping for a while now. It probably served him right for all the fucked-up shit he'd done during their lives, right? Deku had spent years and years yearning for his attention, and Katsuki had never given it to him. Now, there was nothing Katsuki wanted more than for Deku to just fucking remember everything and go back to the bond they had built, but there was nothing he could do other than wait.

A dreadful thought appeared in his head and Katsuki felt his stomach twist. What if it took years until Deku regained his physical form? What if he had to wait for *years* to get his Deku back, in the same way that Deku waited for years to be in good terms with Katsuki?

That would be the universe's final punchline, right? Because Deku was weak and tired and still recovering. He could barely get off his bed without help; how long would it take for him to be fit for training again? Months? Years?

And what about his studies? He was fucking quirkless, now; no one other than All Might and Katsuki knew about that, of course, but he *was*. Once Deku was fit to go back to classes, he wouldn't be able to attend the Hero Course, would he? Unless Aizawa sensei gave him special clearance to skip physical training due to his current condition.

But, if that happened, Deku would fall behind and he would certainly not graduate with them – fuck, every second he spent on that hospital bed not studying was a class he fell behind on. A step away from *graduation*. And what would be the fucking point in becoming number one if Katsuki's major rival and opposition was a fucking loser who couldn't even graduate in time?

He took a deep breath, trying to calm his increasingly racing thoughts before he fucking lost it.

If need arose, he would help Deku study. He could do that, right? If there was a person who could help shitty Deku make up for months of skipped classes and get back to the level of the rest of their class, that person was Katsuki. And maybe the fucker could also take extra classes or something like that. Aizawa sensei surely wouldn't let him fall so far behind – it wasn't the nerd's actual fault he'd been sent to hell and back, after all, so it wouldn't be fair if he was the only one who got punished for it. And maybe Katsuki could help him train, too; or make a specific workout routine and come up with a special diet so that Deku could regain his muscular mass faster once he was medically fit to do so.

Yeah, there was no logical reason for him to freak out so hard, because he could definitely help Deku get back on the game. Not only because that was the fastest way for Deku to just take his damn quirk back already and regain his memories along with it, but because Katsuki decided he needed the little asshole to graduate with him. He couldn't have it any other way.

No matter how badly Katsuki had treated him, how badly Katsuki had bullied him, how badly Katsuki had abused him, Deku had *always* been there. From day fucking one. If anything, the nerd was the one single constant in Katsuki's life. He'd been there when he discovered his quirk, he'd been there when Katsuki grew up, he'd been there when Katsuki got into UA. Deku had been there with Katsuki for every single key-moment in his life.

In a way, it was only right and natural Deku had gotten into the same high school as Katsuki did – wherever he went, Deku followed. It had always been like that. He had always been right there, even if Katsuki hated it, even if he took it for granted, with his '*matte yo!'*s and his '*Kacchan, sugoi!'*s.

It would feel wrong not to have Deku there with him by the time he graduated and became a pro hero. It would feel really fucking wrong, no matter how much he hated himself for feeling that way about annoying, irritating *Deku*, of all people.

~~It would feel wrong if Deku wasn't in his life for the rest of his days~~.

Katsuki made up his mind. Once Deku was back on his feet and ready to go back to training, he would fucking help the nerd. Not that he would ever tell him the reason why, and not that he would ever call it *help*, but he hoped that, once Deku took One For All back, he would understand Katsuki's reasons.

Soul-Deku would be able to understand. This Deku, who didn't remember shit... Well. This one was a bit of a dumb asshole. A bit too oblivious, a bit too weak, but certainly a dumb asshole. Katsuki hated him and loved him at the same time; despised him and worried about him, all simultaneously. And he fucking *hated* it. Things were way simpler back when he could settle to feeling only one thing at the time, at *all* times.

He decided it was about time focused back on his Sign Language lesson and *stopped. Thinking. About. Deku.* Deku had already taken over too many of his thoughts, and this was getting on the verge of ridiculous now.

When had he gotten to this fucking stage? Just because the nerd was in the hospital, it didn't mean Katsuki should think about him so often. Even if it took him a lifetime, Deku would be fine. There was nothing to worry about. Katsuki needed to fucking study hard and keep himself on the top, he didn't have time for –

For –

Wait.

Wait a *fucking* minute.

Katsuki went back a couple of minutes in his online sign language class, because his mind had been wandering but his eyes caught something that called his attention. He pressed play again and started paying close attention to the video and the gestures the teacher was making.

He paused. Took a look at his notes. Stared at the screen. Pressed play again.

No fucking way.

He repeated the process. Paused. Took a look at his notes. Stared at the screen. Pressed play again. Over and over, until he had almost memorized that entire fucking video segment.

His blood boiled. His blood fucking *boiled*. In a way it hadn't boiled in a long time, not since he started anger management, not since he watched Deku fucking kick the bucket and come back to life.

His blood boiled in a way that made him forget all about the cheesy, melodramatic shit he'd been thinking in the past minutes. In a way that made his growing affection for Deku become fucking history in the matter of seconds. In a way that made him almost remember what it was like, feeling nothing but raw, unprocessed rage.

Because Katsuki? Katsuki was about to roast the fucking nerd into *oblivion*.

Good words and good deeds his *ass*.

"You son of a fucking *bitch*".

"Oh! Bakubro! I didn't expect to see you –"

"What the *fuck* do you think you're doing, damn Deku?!"

“U-Uh... K-Kacchan...”

“Whoa, hey, man, hold up. What's going on?”

“Out of my fucking *way*, Kaminari. I'm about to *roast* this damn nerd”.

“Uh...”

“K-K-Kacchan, w-what...?”

“Don’t go all mumble-y-rumbly on me, you *asshole*. You have no trouble talking your ass out to these extras, you think I don’t see that? I’m done with your shit, so you’d better fucking spit it right now. And don’t even *think* about using that shitty sign language, unless you want me to shove those nerd hands of yours up your ass!”, Katsuki shouted, and yeah, there went his plan to *calmly* tell Deku about how he felt regarding that specific subject. *Sorry, I guess, Mrs. Therapist*.

Izuku blushed violently at the words, and Kaminari’s wide eyes were darting frantically between the two boys, as if he didn’t know what to do. Before he tried to intervene, which seemed to be his current plan, Katsuki pointed a finger at his face.

“You. Dunce Face. *Out”*, he spat, and then he turned on his heels to point the same finger at Deku. “You. Shithead. *Start talking”*.

*“*Dude, I mean, calm down a bit, his talking-thing is better, but he’s still having some trouble –”

“What did I *fucking tell you*, Kaminari?!”, Katsuki spat furiously. Kaminari raised his hands in front of himself in a peace gesture, taking a series of steps back towards the door.

“Ooh, man, I’m not sure I should leave you alone with Midoriya when you’re like this –“

“K-Kaminari-kun”, Izuku called from the bed, his voice sounding calm even though there was a frown on his face. “It’s ok. K-Kacchan wants to… uh, to… Uh… T-Talk…?”

“More like *commit a damn murder*, from the look of it”, Kaminari pointed out, worried, sending a disapproving frown at Katsuki.

“Yeah, and you’ll be next if you don’t fuck off!”, Katsuki shouted. “I’m having this talk with shitty Deku and it’s fucking personal, so you’re not staying around to listen to it!”

“It’s o-ok”, Izuku said again from the bed, nodding at Kaminari even though the look on his face was clearly concerned. “W-We can catch up… uh… hm…”

“Later?”, Kaminari suggested, frowning in concern and sympathy.

“Y-Y-Yeah, t-that”, Izuku nodded, offering him a smile that didn’t quite reach his eyes. “O-Ok?”

Kaminari hesitated, his arms still raised in surrender.

“You sure, man?”, he asked, and that was *enough*. Katsuki marched his way to him, grabbed Kaminari by the collar of his shirt, open the door and threw him out like a trash bag despite the boy’s yelp of protest.

Once the door was closed behind Kaminari, Katsuki turned on his heels to glare at Deku, his crimson eyes sparkling with rage. If he hadn’t been so blinded by emotion, he would have noticed the way Izuku’s heart monitor sped up, but instead, his better judgement clouded by a veil of anger and betrayal, he marched his way to the boy with a vein throbbing in his temple and his lips contorted into a snarl.

“K-Kacchan”, Izuku said, hesitant. He lifted his hand and started to sign, but before he could go farther than “*what*”, Katsuki grabbed his wrist – not hard enough to hurt him, but hard enough to make him stop and quite possibly give him a fright. Izuku’s eyes widened.

“You think you’re *better* than me, nerd?”, Katsuki growled, his voice no longer a shout but a low, guttural sound.

Izuku’s shocked face immediately scrunched up into a frown of confusion and indignation.

“W-What?”

“I said: You think you’re fucking *better* than me?”, Katsuki growled again. Izuku stared up at him in confusion.

“… N-No”.

“Then why the *fuck* would you let me act like I’m some sort of dumbass? You thought it would be fucking *funny*?”

Izuku blinked up at him, cheeks earning a pink tinge. His eyes were becoming moist.

“You thought I wouldn’t fucking *find out*?”, Katsuki asked with a scoff, letting go of Izuku’s wrist a bit too abruptly. The boy’s arm flopped on the bed. “Or did you think it would fucking take me so long to do so that I’d forget all about it? Or did you think I’m a *brainless loser* like you and I wouldn’t *remember*?”

Izuku’s mouth was opening and closing as Katsuki spoke, looking like he couldn’t find the proper words to voice his thoughts.

“K-Kacchan, I don’t – I d-d-don’t k-know, uh, w-what, uh, w-what –“, he raised his hand to sign something again, but with one single fulminating glare from Katsuki, he hesitantly put his hands down in surrender.

“I was taking my usual online classes on sign language this morning, Deku. So imagine my surprise when I tried to get ahead of myself and skip a level, and then I saw that the shit you’ve been signing recently, which I fucking thought was just you being a clumsy idiot who didn’t know proper sign language, was actually *advanced vocabulary* I hadn’t learned yet”.

Izuku looked away from him in embarrassment, eyes wide and hesitant. A bit of recognition sparkled in green, and Katsuki scoffed, pacing the room in front of Izuku’s bed.

“I thought you were just doing the wrong signs, and I kept fucking correcting you, but that wasn’t it, was it?”, he snarled. “You were actually fucking *ahead* of me. And you fucking knew it. And you didn’t fucking say anything. You just let me correct you and trash talk you like an idiot”.

Izuku blushed in embarrassment, biting his lower lip.

“What, am I fucking joke to you?”, Katsuki insisted when the boy remained silent. “Were you having a laugh at me, you asshole? Is that why you actually *speak* to everyone who comes by, but keep using the fucking sign language with me? To fucking shove it in my face that you know more than the actual *half-deaf* guy?”

“N-No!”, Izuku protested without missing a beat. His eyes were sparkling with tears of anticipation, and from the way his hands were shaking, he was probably nervous. His eyes met Katsuki’s again, full of embarrassment, but also full of regret. “K-Kacchan, that – it was – wasn’t – it… Uh…”, he stuttered, sounding like he couldn’t properly find the words. His hands started to shake harder. “It wasn’t. I swear. I – I can’t – I can’t –“, he sniffed, frustrated.

Izuku turned on his side, trembling hand reaching for the notepad on his bedside stand. Katsuki scoffed, shaking his head.

“Oh, fucking *really*? You can talk to Icy Hot, you can talk to fucking Dunce Face, but with me you have to write shit down?”, he protested, still feeling angry.

Izuku ignored the criticism and continued to try and reach for the notepad, but his hand was shaking so hard that he wouldn’t have been able to grab it, even if he managed to reach it. Katsuki rolled his eyes and marched over to the bedside, grabbing the notepad and a pen and shoving it at Izuku, only to cross his arms above his chest and glare at the boy.

Katsuki didn’t know what had pissed him off harder – the fact that Deku was ahead of him or the fact that Deku was ahead of him and tried to *pretend he wasn’t*. Because that was the primordial problem in their relationship, and a problem he had thought they had solved already – Deku looking down on him.

Soul-Deku had sworn he had never looked down on Katsuki, that he only ever admired him, but in all fucking honesty, Katsuki could see no other reason why Deku would have lied about this shit. He had seen Deku’s books. He had recognized Deku’s ability from the online classes he’d seen. Deku had decided to learn sign language and he had learned it so well he had already surpassed Katsuki, and it pissed him the *fuck* off.

Because he’d been trying hard to teach Deku what he knew, and he’d thought he was actually helping him. More than that – he had actually enjoyed giving Deku those classes, for some godforsaken reason he couldn’t really understand. And now, he had found out not only was Deku ahead of him, but Deku had *allowed* Katsuki to correct him on shit he *knew* Katsuki didn’t know. Katsuki had been making a fucking fool of himself this entire time and Deku hadn’t said anything and it made him pissed as *fuck*.

He knew they still had that rivalry thing where they kept trying to surpass each other to become number one, but this… This shit was different. Being a hero was a profession. This

shit was personal. This was close to home. Not only because with his condition, Katsuki actively, physically *needed* sign language in his life, but because this… Well.

This was cheesy as fuck, but Katsuki had thought of this as making a connection with Deku.

Because it was hard to connect with him, now that their souls were separated and Deku had no memory of their time together. It was hard to connect with him, now that he could no longer feel what Deku was feeling. And this whole sign language thing was the new personal way they had found to communicate, something that only the two of them shared, much like the soulbond, and something that, out of everybody Katsuki knew, only *Deku* had bothered to try and learn.

And Katsuki had thought, rather naively, it seems, that Deku had bothered to try and learn it not only because he could barely speak and Katsuki could barely hear, but because he *cared*. He cared that Katsuki had hearing issues now, and he wanted to be able to communicate with him.

But apparently, this had just been about surpassing each other again. About their shitty fucking rivalry, a rivalry that Katsuki didn't mind having on the battlefield or on the hero career, a rivalry he actually *enjoyed* having on those fields, but one that he really didn't want to fucking have when it came to… this.

This was him, trusting Deku and actually trying to build something like a friendship with him, after years and years and years of failed attempts (of Deku's part). The last thing he needed was for this to become a competition too, much for his surprise. For the first time, he didn't want to compete against Deku.

Not over this.

No one else knew what they were talking about when they signed at each other. It was like having something similar to the soulbond again. Something only they shared, only they understood. Something *theirs.* And now… Now he found Deku actually didn't need his help, or his classes, or his explanations. Deku probably didn't even think about the sign language the same way as Katsuki, because he didn't even fucking remember the soulbond anyway, so why would he miss it?

Because Deku was ahead of him. Deku knew more than he did. And Deku had fucking *led him on* like a dumb motherfucker.

Deku finished writing down whatever he was writing and handed the notepad over to Katsuki with trembling hands, his eyes moist and wide. Katsuki yanked the thing out of Izuku's hands a bit more abruptly than he needed to, bringing the notepad closer to his face and trying to decipher the shaky, almost childlike writing.

Sorry, Kacchan, I didn't mean to humiliate you I swear. I was just worried because I could barely say more than two words at the time and I wanted to be able to communicate with you properly, so I studied a lot. I wasn't laughing at you. I should have told you about it when you tried to correct me but I didn't want to make you angry or upset

Katsuki stared at him with a glare. Izuku was rubbing his closed fist against his chest in what meant “sorry”, his eyes wide and apologetic and still moist. He looked so weak and upset in that fucking hospital bed, overgrown hair falling all over his eyes, that Katsuki realized there was no way Deku was lying to him.

It suddenly dawned on Katsuki exactly what he had done, with the clarity and sobriety that felt like a bucket of ice water to the face. He had done exactly what he had been told and taught not to do, but always ended up doing anyway – he had let his emotions take the best of him, and he had let them take control.

He had let them send him screaming and shouting to Deku’s hospital fucking room, yelling accusations to the boy’s face, when he knew – he had already learned that Deku didn’t look down on him. Never had, probably never would. If anything, what Deku always seemed to do was look *up* to him.

I know you think horrible things of me, and I don’t know what I could have possibly done to make you think them

Katsuki sighed, closing his eyes and trying to regain his cool.

Apparently, I was wrong, since you continue to see me as this horrible, fake person, while, to me, you’re nothing less than the very incarnation of victory!

Yeah. Guilt hit him like a brick to the face, and out of all the new emotions he had found himself capable of feeling in the past months, this was the one he hated the *most*, without doubt.

He tossed the notepad to the side, allowing it to flop to the bed, and rolled his eyes with a sigh, approaching Deku. The boy continued to sign “sorry” non-stop, his rhythm growing more frantic as Katsuki approached him.

Katsuki grabbed his wrist again, making him stop. He stared deep into Deku’s eyes, face impassive.

“You’ve been overworking yourself?”, he asked simply, his voice so absent of anger and fury that it contrasted sharply with his tone from moments before.

“I – I-I…”, Izuku tried, wrist still held tightly in Katsuki’s grasp.

“Don’t fucking lie to me”, Katsuki added sharply, eyes narrowing. He glared at Izuku. “I’m done screaming at you. Just tell me the damn truth”.

Izuku lowered his gaze, his head bowing slightly and a stray curl of green hair falling over his eyes. His mop of a hair enveloped his head like an ugly green halo.

“I’ll take that as a yes”, Katsuki scoffed.

“I – I didn’t… I didn’t…”, Izuku sighed, taking a deep breath and closing his eyes. He looked frustrated, as if he couldn’t get the words out no matter how hard he tried. “M-M-Mean… to”, he mustered after a while. Katsuki let go of his wrist, stepping back.

“Doesn’t matter what you meant, douchebag. You still look tired as hell”.

Izuku raised a shaky hand to his face, putting his stray curl back into place. He stared up at Katsuki.

“P-Please, Kacchan, d-don’t… d-don’t t-t-t… uh…”, he attempted. Katsuki rolled his eyes, grabbing the notepad and throwing it at Izuku with disdain. He shakily scribbled down “*don’t tell All Might or my mom or Recovery Girl*”, to which Katsuki promptly rolled his eyes.

“I *should* tell them. I fucking should, damn Deku”, he scoffed, a grumpy expression on his face. Izuku looked away in embarrassment, and for some reason that pissed Katsuki off even further. “You’re not a fucking baby. You should know better than to pull that sort of crap after you’ve been through all the shit you’ve been through”, he scolded, crossing his arms above his chest in disapproval.

Izuku frowned at him, giving him a look that was full of disbelief. A look that almost said *And you should know better than to barge into a sick person’s hospital room screaming accusations at them*.

Katsuki squinted his eyes at the boy. Izuku hadn’t said anything, but the look in his eyes said enough. It was filled with a defiance that he didn’t have the ability to voice yet.

“Don’t give me that fucking look. You know I’m right. And just because I barged in shouting at you doesn’t mean I’m in the wrong about this. I thought you were being a smug asshole, trying to shove it on my face, but turns out you’re just really fucking dumb”, he scoffed.

Izuku sighed and leaned back against his pillows, looking slightly impatient. The reaction made Katsuki angry.

“Don’t fucking test your luck”, he pointed a warning finger at Izuku. “I’m still pissed at you”.

Katsuki grabbed the notepad again, yanked out the last pages Deku had written and shoved them into the pocket of his pants.

“Don’t want anyone reading this and accusing me of being an accomplice in letting a shitty invalid overwork himself back into a coma”, he explained, placing the notepad back on the nightstand. “*Honestly*, Deku, what the hell were you even thinking?”

Izuku had the decency to lower his head in embarrassment at the scolding, but he didn’t look like he was full of regrets. Katsuki walked back to his bedside, crossing his arms above his chest and giving Deku a look that was full of disapproval. He stared at the nerd, who didn’t meet his eyes, taking him in, trying to read him.

“I should tell your mom about this shit”, Katsuki said, and that was enough to send Izuku’s head snapping in his direction, eyes wide. “But I won’t. She’s worried enough as it is”.

Izuku sighed in relief, probably thinking Katsuki wouldn’t notice it. The feeling was short lived.

“I don’t see *why* I shouldn’t tell Recovery Girl, though”, Katsuki scoffed.

“K-K-Ka – K-Kacc…”, Izuku attempted pitifully. Katsuki sighed and stopped him before he could get too far.

“Shut up. You could have done some real damage, you idiot. Do you understand that?”

Izuku blushed slightly, but bowed his head down and nodded. He looked small on the bed, smaller than Katsuki was used to seeing him. Suddenly, to even consider that this person in front of him could be trying to make a fool out of him, to turn him into a joke, to mock him by learning faster than him… It felt ludicrous.

“I won’t tell anyone about this shit you pulled”, Katsuki settled for saying. “But if I find out you’re overworking yourself again, I’ll tell not just Recovery Girl, but the entire fucking school, *and* I’ll kick your ass, whether you’re still in a hospital or not. You won’t hear the end of it from your shitty friends, and All Might will probably help me smack you. Are we clear?”

Izuku looked a bit confused, but he nodded.

“Y-Yeah”, he managed to say.

“Stupid asshole”, Katsuki scoffed, leaning on the edge of Deku’s bed in a half-sat, half-standing position. “I still can’t believe you didn’t tell me you were learning it on your own. Let me sit here for hours teaching you shit you already knew”, he grunted, staring at the window. Izuku frowned.

“I… I liked”, he mustered, staring at Katsuki with sincerity. “D-Didn’t want, uh… you t-to… to…”

“Stop?”, Katsuki provided, raising an eyebrow.

Izuku nodded.

“Oh, fuck off”, Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“M-M-M…”, Izuku attempted, but no word came out. It filled Katsuki with anger and second-hand embarrassment.

“If you can’t just speak up like you do to everyone else then just *sign* it, you damn nerd. I know damn well you can do it, and it’s better than hearing your useless mumbling”.

Izuku bit his lower lip and signed something in the lines of “*I didn’t want you to stop visiting*”.

“Oh, yeah, sure, because the only reason I bothered dragging my ass over here every day was to teach you sign language. Get over yourself, shitty Deku”, he grunted.

Izuku frowned. Then, after a few moments of hesitant silence, he signed “why?”

Katsuki sighed, staring off at the distance.

“You’ll just have to wait and find out”.

Izuku sighed, still looking frustrated. He signed something that could be roughly translated to “*does this have to do with the memory loss?*”, to which Katsuki stood up properly and took a step away from the bed.

“We’re not talking about that yet”.

“*Why not?*”, Deku signed.

“Just fucking *because*; don’t second guess me. Also, you’re overworked and looking like shit. When’s the last time someone washed your hair? That shit’s greasier than the food from the cafeteria”.

Izuku raised a hand to his curls and pulled one of them to his eye-level, trying to check and see if Katsuki was being serious. He frowned, and even though his hair was long enough for him to be able to see it properly from that position, his eyes still got crisscross in a way that shouldn’t be so fucking adorable as he stared at the damn curl. Katsuki batted Deku’s hand away so that he’d *stop doing that with his face* and huffed out a breath.

“It’s also too long. You look like you have a bush on your damn head”, he added, making Izuku’s frown deepen. “You should get it cut”.

What, you don’t think I have the skills to cut your fucking hair? Is that it?

Well, yes!

Now you’re just asking me to put another use to my damn scissors.

I just mean I’ve never seen you cut anyone’s hair! How do I know you won’t mess mine up?

Izuku stared up at him, silent. Katsuki stared back.

“What?”, he snapped. Izuku tilted his head to the side, a curl falling atop his eyes in a way that almost served as an argument.

“N-N-Nothing, I j-just…”, Izuku attempted, frowning, and then switching back to sign language. “*I thought you could give me a haircut*”.

Katsuki scoffed. The fuck was that supposed to *mean*?

“As if”.

“*Why not?*”, he signed.

“The fuck would I do that for?”, Katsuki glared at him. “I ain’t your personal servant”.

“*Sorry*”, Izuku signed, looking slightly disappointed. “*You’re right*”.

Katsuki stared at him. Goddamn freckly cheeks with those pleading eyes and ridiculous hair. The amount of green curls made his head look even smaller and bonier; unhealthier, in a way.

“I’m gonna get going”, Katsuki announced. “Got better shit to do than stand here staring at you”.

“O-Ok”, Izuku stuttered.

“Don’t expect me to come see you later”, Katsuki added coldly, almost resentfully. Honestly, what the hell was Deku *thinking*? “This already counts as today’s visit”.

“Oh”, Izuku said, and Katsuki ignored the renewed hint of disappointment in his tone.

“And if I find out you’re pushing yourself too far again, I’m gonna shove all of those books up your stupid ass. You’d better get some rest, you damn nerd”, was what Katsuki said above his shoulder before walking out of the room without looking back.

Hatsume stared at him as if she had no clue who he was.

“You said the hearing aid would be ready this week”, Katsuki clarified in a deadpan, trying his best not to snap at her with a furious shout. No matter how angry the girl’s lack of recognition made him – what, did she take him for a fucking *extra*?! –, he had to admit he had already achieved his daily quota of screaming and raging.

“Oh! Right! You’re the ear guy!”, she exclaimed, face sparkling with remembrance.

She rushed back into her workshop, searching through several messy drawers and boxes until she successfully retrieved a tiny box with a hearing aid, all at the same time Katsuki’s hands curled into fists and he bounced one of his legs non-stop in his best attempt not to blow her workshop up for reducing Bakugou fucking Katsuki to something as simple as *the ear guy*.

“There you go”, Hatsume handed him the box, which Katsuki immediately snatched out of her hold with a grumpy look on his face. She seemed untroubled by the sudden movement, and continued: “I’m working on a better version of it, but you can use this one ‘til it’s ready. It won’t give you feedback, but the external structure is more fragile because I had to use a material –“

“I don’t care”, Katsuki cut her off before she could get side-tracked on the techno-rant he could sense was coming. She had already tested his patience enough for him to just stand there and take her rambling. “Just tell me how it works”.

Hatsume didn't seem offended by the interruption, and instead just took the thing from his hands again to give him a demonstration.

"You can use this baby exactly as you're wearing your current one, the only difference is that it's lighter and smaller, so it shouldn't hurt your ear as much. Just for safe measure I put this adapted cushion on the base as well, in case it does hurt. But that also means it's more fragile because of the material I used to make it lighter, so you should handle it carefully and possibly avoid getting hit in the head while you wear it. I'm currently working on another baby that's basically the same as this one but it's made of a stronger alloy, since you're a hero and probably get knocked in the head a lot – you wouldn't want it to break every time you face a villain, and what kind of gear-designer would I be if I had to keep making a new hearing aid for you every time you go off to save the day? –, but anyway, with the new hero expo that's coming up I haven't been getting much time to work on this specific baby. So, I would say, maybe get back in –", she checked her wristwatch, and then a dusty calendar on her desk that was all scribbled up. "Uh, three weeks? Three weeks, and I'll probably have the final version. But you can wear this one in the meantime", she handed the new hearing aid back to him.

Katsuki glared at her, more than pissed off by the ranting he knew to expect, and snatched the thing off her hand again, shoving it in his pocket and giving her an annoyed look. Hatsume turned her back on him and went back to whatever she had been doing before his arrival.

He was ready to sprint out of that damn place at once and go about his business, but something she said had called his attention. He lingered at the workshop for a few silent moments, watching as she worked and completely ignored his presence there. Eventually, Katsuki spoke up.

"What hero expo?", he asked, curious but putting an effort into sounding indifferent. He hadn't heard about that, and despite his growth in the past months, he still felt pretty angry whenever people knew more than he did – hence the whole shitshow that had just taken place at Deku's infirmary room.

"I'm sorry, what?", Hatsume asked him with an absentminded tone as if she had no idea what he was still doing there, not even bothering to look at him above her shoulder as she worked.

"You said you haven't been getting time to work on this because of a hero expo that's coming up", Katsuki said, annoyed. Thank fuck Doctor Matsuo was a thing in his life, otherwise he would have already thrown a tantrum in the middle of the workshop.

"Oh, right, you probably haven't heard about that yet", she shrugged, focused on her task at hands. "They haven't announced it to the public. There's this hero museum opening up in a while and there's going to be all sorts of activities in the first night, including a contest of best support items, which is how I learned about it. So I obviously signed up for that, right?", she turned her head to smile at him only to turn it back to her desk less than a second later. "Do you need anything else?", she added as an afterthought, probably as a dismissal rather than out of actual interest.

Katsuki fumed. He hated being dismissed – actually, he was pretty sure he hated every single thing about Hatsume's personality – but, despite his grandest wishes, he couldn't really shout

at her or blow her things up after she paid him such a nice favor for free. He hadn't even taken a proper look at the new hearing device, but from what he had seen, she had put a lot of effort into making it as comfortable and functional as possible for him.

"No", he responded after taking a deep, calming breath, still sounding a bit more bitter than he had intended. He supposed *not* blowing her shit to hell was the closest he could currently get to thanking her after she annoyed him so much (even if he was sure Doctor Matsuo would disagree).

He turned on his heels to leave at that, but before he could get too far Hatsume added:

"You can come and vote for me, by the way! Actually, I sort of need you to. I'm really eager to win this contest", she added in a tone that didn't leave place for a discussion.

"Whatever", Katsuki responded, and yeah, maybe voting for this crazy girl's inventions was a better way to thank her for her effort than *not* ruining her entire portfolio. "When is it?"

"In twelve months. I'll send you a save-the-date", she promised, her back still turned to him and only paying him half-attention to the conversation. Katsuki squinted and scowled at her.

"What the *fuck*? Why are you so worked up if you still have a whole year to finish the damn thing?"

"Oh, I didn't sign just *one* of my babies up. Like I said, I'm going to win this contest", she gave him another smile that didn't last more than a second before she had already shifted focus.

Huh.

Fine, ok, maybe Katsuki didn't hate her *that* much. He could see something in her determined eyes and dismissal for others that was a bit too familiar to him.

(He vaguely wondered if his way of dealing with people made them feel as annoyed at him as Hatsume's attitude towards others made him feel pissed off).

"You should get some fucking sleep", was what Katsuki offered her as a response, almost sure Hatsume hadn't heard him over the loud noises of her workshop as he left.

Actually, putting some thought into it, it wouldn't be too far off to assume she had already forgotten about him altogether by the time he stepped out.

He set his tray down on the table with a loud clack and sat down beside Kirishima, a grumpy look on his face.

“Bakugou! You looking good, man! Is that a new hearing aid?”, the boy exclaimed cheerfully.

“What is it to you?”, he responded sharply.

“Ouch!”, Sero laughed, whereas Mina hissed loudly and Kaminari made a face.

“Just teasing you, Shitty Hair”, Katsuki rolled his eyes, explaining himself before Kirishima’s feelings got too hurt by the banter. The last thing he needed was to be in bad terms with his best friends so soon after they started talking again. Taking a bite of his food, he added: “Yeah, it’s new. Picked it up today”.

“Nice! So you did listen to me about that Hatsume girl!”, Kirishima said with triumph. Katsuki rolled his eyes again.

“Is this about that feedback issue?”, Mina asked. “Is it solved?”

“For now, yeah”, Katsuki shrugged. “Doesn’t mean you assholes can go back to screaming and being loud as fuck when you’re near me”.

“Double standards much?”, Sero raised an eyebrow at him.

“Shut the hell up”, Katsuki said in between bites, not looking at the boy.

“So, Bakugou”, Kaminari leaned forwards on the table. “How’s Midoriya? Still alive?”

Katsuki felt all blood drain from his face at that, and something about his reaction must have shown everyone at the table that those had been the wrong choice of *fucking words*. Mina’s and Kirishima’s eyes widened, whereas Sero’s head snapped towards Kaminari so fast that he could have broken his neck. Katsuki was frozen mid-way through taking another bite of his food, hand lifted midair, staring at Kaminari as if he had seen a fucking ghost before his face grew red with anger and he snarled.

“I – I just asked because – because you said that thing about m-murdering him! I didn’t mean –! It – It was a joke!”, Kaminari tried to explain, grimacing.

“Wrong choice of words, dude”, Sero reprehended with a disapproving eyeroll.

“How can he be so dumb?”, Mina sighed under her breath.

“Sorry! That was stupid of me, I didn’t mean it like – ah, *shit*”, he sighed, dropping his head in defeat. “Sorry, man”.

Katsuki glared daggers at him, hating how such a stupid phrase had caused his heart to start hammering in his chest. This only served to make his bad mood even sourer.

“Next time you get out of your shitty room, remember to take your fucking brains with you”, Katsuki spat through gritted teeth, glaring at his bowl of food. All eyes were on him, as if waiting for him to continue. “And the nerd’s fine. I just wanted to talk to him”, he added for good measure, hoping that his shitty nosy friends would sense the tension and drop the subject.

Katsuki should have foreseen that, since his friends were dumb as fuck, none of them would do something as simple as *drop the subject*. If anything, his statement only made them even more fucking curious, and as he continued to eat his food in silence, he could see Mina lean forwards on the table and Sero straighten himself on his seat through his peripheral vision. Kaminari was the one who asked the question they were all thinking.

“A-About what?”, he tried, offering Katsuki a small, nervous smile.

Katsuki scoffed, counting back from ten in his head and trying his mightiest not to snap his hashi in two.

“None of your *damn* business”, he responded coldly.

“Why don’t we change the subject, huh?”, Kirishima tried, offering all his friends a wide smile. He knew, probably more than everyone else at that table, just how sensitive the Midoriya-subject was for Katsuki, and since he was seating right beside Katsuki, he could probably see the vein already popping and throbbing at his temple.

“Yeah, yeah, let’s change the subject!”, Mina encouraged, even though she did look curious to know the answer to Kaminari’s question. She probably knew Kirishima – and Katsuki – well enough to know when to drop the ball, though, unlike the electric boy. “What about that expo thing everyone’s been talking about, huh? Are you guys going?”, she asked, face and voice full of enthusiasm.

“I don’t know, man, I’m not really a fan of museums”, Sero shrugged with indifference.

“I have to second Sero on that. Museums? Not really my thing. There are rarely any cute girls around there, so what’s the point?”, Kaminari added, flowing into the new subject naturally as if he hadn’t been an inch away of being murdered by Katsuki a mere moment before.

“God, is that all you ever think about?”, Mina rolled her eyes. “Have you considered that a trip to a museum has to do with watching the art, not the girls?”

“The *girls* are the art, Mina”, Kaminari said with a smug expression, leaning back on his chair.

“You’ve been spending too much time with Mineta”, Mina criticized.

“Wait, wait, hold the fuck up. How the hell do you all even know about that expo shit?”, Katsuki interrupted with a frown, feeling slightly *more* pissed off, if that was even possible. When Hatsume told him this museum opening was happening in a year and had only been announced to the support students, he had felt a bit better about being left out, but now, from

the looks of it, a bunch of extras knew about that stuff already. *Before* him. What kind of fucking day was he having?!

“Ohh, Bakugou, you know how it is”, Mina waved a hand dismissively. “One person tells another, and next thing you know the whole school is discussing whether they’ll go or not. I’m pretty sure I’ll go, if I can! It sounds like fun, and from what I’ve heard there will be contests and meet & greets with some heroes!”, she exclaimed.

“Will Crimson Riot be there?”, Kirishima asked with excitement, suddenly very interested.

“Ok, calm down, fanboy”, Sero teased him.

“They haven’t announced which heroes will be there yet –“, Mina started.

“Maybe there will be none and this is all just a marketing strategy to lure people into a museum”, Kaminari pointed out with a shrug.

“Why would anyone want to *lure* people into a museum?”, Mina squinted her eyes at him, scoffing with humor.

“Uh, because no one would go in otherwise?”, Sero said at the same time Kaminari exclaimed:

“Because there are no cute girls there!”

“Ok, I see why Kaminari doesn’t want to go”, Kirishima chuckled. “But what have you got against museums, man?”, he asked Sero.

“If I wanted to listen to people talk about boring history for hours, I’d just pay attention in class!”, Sero explained.

“Wow. No wonder why your grades suck”, Mina rolled her eyes again, but there was a smile on her lips.

“You’re one to talk! Your grades suck, too!”, Sero accused, offended. “Kaminari, back me up on this. You’re dumb too”.

“Hey!”, Kaminari protested.

“What? It’s just the truth!”

“Can’t argue with that”, Kaminari gave in easily. “Us dumb people should stick together. Mina’s the odd one out for wanting to go”, he pointed a finger at her.

“Why do you even want to go, man?”, Sero frowned at her. “I thought you were dumb like us!”

“What are you trying to prove? Just stay true to your dumbness!”, Kaminari reproved.

“I’m not dumb! And I want to go because it sounds like fun!”, Mina retorted. “There will be activities and heroes there! You’re the stupid one for missing an opportunity like this! Maybe we can even find some sponsors –“

“Yes, you’re dumb!”, Sero interrupted her, the playful tone evident in his voice. Kaminari nodded solemnly beside his friend.

“Let me –“, Mina attempted.

“Everyone in the Bakusquad is dumb except for Bakugou!”, Sero interrupted her again, just to keep the joke running.

“I –“, Mina tried.

“Bakugou’s the odd one out!”, Sero accused, pointing a finger at Katsuki.

“Stop saying I’m dumb!”, Mina protested.

“Hey, I’m not dumb, either!”, Kirishima supported her.

“Dude, we’re *all* dumb here!”, Sero laughed. “Bakugou, c’mon. Make them face the truth”, he nudged Katsuki’s arm suggestively.

“Elbows is right. You’re all dumb”, Katsuki said in a deadpan as he continued to silently chew his lunch, not paying them much attention.

“See? The group leader has spoken!”, Sero exclaimed with triumph.

“How could you!”, Mina gasped at Katsuki with fake-betrayal in her tone.

“Just face it, Mina”, Kaminari tapped her shoulder. “You’re one of us”.

“I don’t want to be dumb!”, she pouted, frowning.

“It’s too late! You’re already part of the group! You too, Kirishima!”, Kaminari exclaimed.

“One of us! One of us! One of us!”, Sero chanted.

“Stop that!”, Mina protested.

“You guys are making such a scene…”, Kirishima lowered his head in embarrassment as a few people at the cafeteria stared at their table.

“The only one of us allowed to go to this expo is Bakugou”, Sero announced.

“What, will you hold me back if I try to go?”, Mina raised a challenging eyebrow at him.

“No, but they’ve got dumb detectors at the entrance”, Kaminari laughed. “They’ll kick you out if you try to go in”.

“And you know that because they used you as lab rat to make the dumb detectors, right?”, Mina teased.

“Hey!”

“Ouch, burn, Ashido!”, Kirishima cheered, high-fiving her.

“There’s a reason her quirk is *acid*!”, Sero laughed. Kaminari crossed his arms above his chest, pouting.

“You guys suck”.

“It’s not my fault you’re the dumbest of the group”, Mina shrugged.

“It’s not a competition!”, Kaminari protested.

“Of course it is! You’re the dumbest, Bakugou’s the smartest. I’m the second smartest, Kiri is the third, and Sero is the fourth”, Mina announced.

“Uh, I don’t think you should be second –“, Sero attempted.

“No, Raccoon Eyes is right”, Katsuki commented with little interest in his voice, not looking at any of them as he casually dropped his opinion in the conversation.

“Bakubro! How could you!”, Kirishima told him miserably, taking a hand to his chest in an exaggerated gesture.

“Just saying the truth”, Katsuki shrugged indifferently.

“See? If Bakugou agrees with me, it’s because I’m right”, Mina said with triumph. “Which is why we’re the only ones going to the expo!”

“Yeah, going to a hero expo is totally a Bakugou thing to do, by the way”, Kaminari laughed.

“The hell does that mean?”, Katsuki glared at him. He had expected Kaminari to get nervous again at the angry look he was directing him, but, to his surprise, he seemed unfazed.

“Well… You like to play tough, but you’re a nerd”, Kaminari chuckled confidently. “Going to bed at 8 p.m., never missing a class, always getting good grades… Of *course* you’re the kind of person who goes to a museum for fun”.

Katsuki set his hashi down and leaned forwards on the table, snarling.

“Now listen here, Braindead Pikachu –“, Katsuki growled, but Kirishima held him back with an arm and a nervous smile on his face.

“Easy there, bro”, he chuckled.

“I’ll show you who’s the fucking nerd!”, Katsuki half-shouted.

Before he could fulfill his plan of shoving Kaminari's face into a steaming bowl of soup and make him drown on it, Kirishima held him back despite his best efforts at the exact time Katsuki's phone vibrated in his pocket. Wriggling away from Kirishima's strong hold and huffing out an annoyed breath, Katsuki fished his phone out of his pocket and found a new text from All Might. He ignored his friends' continuous banter in the background and focused on the text, finding that All Might had just asked if they could have their scheduled training-session earlier.

"Lucky for you, I gotta go", he pointed at Kaminari as he stood up, a glare on his face. "But don't think you'll be getting away with calling me a nerd. I'll make you swallow your damn tongue", he scoffed.

"Do you have a death wish, bro?", Sero giggled at a pale Kaminari as Katsuki stood up, grabbed his used tray, and started to walk away.

"He's just dumb like that", Mina teased.

"I'll see you later then, man!", Kirishima waved at Katsuki.

"Yeah, whatever", Katsuki scoffed, not turning to look back at his group of bantering friends.

He had to admit that his day had been pretty weird so far – started off as normal, then escalated to full-of-rage in the span of an online class. He was still angry at Deku, but not as angry as he probably should have been, and his friends had managed to annoy him but that was just usual for them. However, a vague sense of irritation kept looming around him, an irritation which he could not identify or source properly. He kept trying to think about Doctor Matsuo's continuous tips to deal with his anger whenever it got too far, but everything he did felt more like burying his feelings deeper into himself than actually solving his issue.

Training with All Might would probably allow him to let off some steam, at least. He could definitely use that. And maybe he had just gotten up with the wrong foot – Deku's lying, overworking little ass definitely had some level of blame in the escalation of that. Katsuki tried not to focus on those negative feelings that were making his stomach burn, and instead focused on nicer things. He had a better-functioning hearing aid, now. He was on better terms with Kirishima, he would work on getting ahead in all his classes, and Deku…

Deku was getting better. He was certainly taking his fucking time, and his progress was so slow Katsuki could barely even notice it, but he would get there. Eventually.

(He didn't know why his brain classified that as a nice thing to distract himself with, but Katsuki's head had been such a mess lately that he wasn't about to second guess his own damn self).

~~(And who was he kidding? He knew damn well the reason why).~~

“Your progress is astounding, Bakugou shonen”.

Katsuki ran the back of his hand across his forehead to clear away the sweat, smirking at All Might and nodding his acknowledgement of the praise silently.

“But I do have one complaint I need to make”, All Might added after a few seconds.

Right. There was *always* fucking something. He sighed.

“Go ahead”, Katsuki panted, voice sounding grumpy despite his efforts.

“It was brought to my attention that you visited Midoriya shonen earlier today”.

Oh.

“Yeah”, Katsuki said, his face already taking up a sour expression.

He hadn’t been expecting All Might to learn about his visit, if he was being honest, though there was hardly a way out of it. He had made a real scene at the room, and it was unlikely his shouting, however brief, had gone unnoticed by the infirmary’s staff, especially due to the nature of Deku’s presence there. It had actually been a miracle he wasn’t kicked out of Deku’s room right on the spot.

“And that you shouted at him”, All Might added, disapproval evident in his tone.

Katsuki sighed again and looked away from his mentor, hesitant. He suddenly felt like a four-year-old all over again, All Might’s reproaching sitting sour at the bottom of his stomach. He knew better than to let himself be taken down by a teacher criticizing his behavior – he had been hearing that his whole life –, but this situation was different.

This time, in an almost unprecedented stance, Katsuki knew and admitted he was in the wrong. Even though Deku sort of was, too. But that didn’t erase his own blame.

“Yeah”, he grunted, still not meeting All Might’s eyes as he glared at the distance. “But we’re cool, now”.

All Might stared at him in silence. Katsuki finally turned his head to stare back.

“What? I got angry, but then we talked through it. He’s not upset or anything”, he scoffed, a bit annoyed. All Might sighed.

“I thought you had said you weren’t *that* person anymore. You assured me you wouldn’t yell at him in his condition”.

“And I’m *not* that person”, Katsuki retorted angrily, blood rising to his cheeks in rage, embarrassment, and all sorts of confusing feelings he didn’t know how to figure out yet. “I had –a lapse, or something, but it won’t happen again. I’m getting better at controlling it. *And* I already apologized to him”.

All Might raised his eyebrows, looking sincerely surprised.

“You did?”

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“Well, *no*, but he knows I didn’t mean it”.

All Might sighed again.

“What had you so angry that you felt the need to shout at Midoriya shonen while he recovers in a hospital?”, his mentor asked, disapproval evident in his tone.

Katsuki looked away, not really sure he wanted to go into details on that subject with All Might. Despite his initial anger, he didn’t really want to get Deku in trouble by telling his mentor he was pushing himself too hard. Yes, Deku was an asshole for overworking himself in the condition he was in, but Katsuki…

Katsuki knew why he had done that.

And where his past self would have dived in head-first at the opportunity to tell on Deku and make him get punished for being a nerdy little brat, *this* Katsuki didn’t have it in his heart to put the boy into even more trouble, especially after everything he had already endured.

They had already endured.

He could imagine what Deku must be feeling like. Not just because he spent an entire month learning how Deku’s fucked up emotions worked, but because he had been in Deku’s shoes before. Katsuki knew how fucking boring staying in a hospital could be, and he had never stayed in one as long as Deku. If he had almost driven himself mad from boredom after being bedridden for *two days*, he could only imagine what Deku was feeling being bedridden for a fucking *month*.

He didn’t want All Might to take away Deku’s books, notepads, and his little stupid ways to distract himself. He didn’t want the nerd to overwork himself either, but he had already made his message clear to Deku. If he did push himself too far again, Katsuki would tell the whole damn world about it. And Deku knew better than to take Katsuki’s threats lightly.

A sense of anxiety appeared at the bottom of his stomach as he realized that he was doing it again. Taking matters into his own hands, instead of trusting the authorities. This was what had gotten them in trouble from the start, and apparently, Katsuki had learned nothing from it. Rationally, he *knew* he should tell at least All Might about what he had discovered, but the image of Deku staring up at him with miserable, betrayed, tear-damp eyes made him decide against it.

Shit. He was really growing soft.

“It was nothing”, he grunted grumpily, feeling angry at himself. All Might continued to stare at him in silence, waiting.

Katsuki sighed, putting the last of the weights he was carrying down before turning to properly face the former symbol of peace.

“I found out he got ahead of me in the sign language thing”, Katsuki said, careful not to mention anything about Deku overworking himself. And if he ended up sounding a bit too bitter, he could hardly blame himself – he was already doing Deku a favor by not snitching to All Might. “And I got pissed”, he continued, looking away. “But we talked now, so it’s good”.

All Might looked pensive for a while before he crouched down, picked up the weights Katsuki had dropped to the floor, and moved, in silence, towards the boy so that he could put them back into place.

“And you thought Midoriya shonen had done that on purpose, I presume. To surpass you”, he concluded after a while. There was no accusation in his tone – just a sort of tired understanding.

Katsuki chose not to respond. All Might placed the first weight on his back again, and the next one. He endured.

There was silence for a while.

“He didn’t, you know”.

“I know”, Katsuki responded shortly, bitterly, resentfully, trying to signal he didn’t really want to have that conversation without actually saying the words.

Because he wished, for god’s sake, he *wished* Deku had done it out of some corrupted will to be better than Katsuki. He wished Deku had done it to surpass him, or to shove it on his face, or to take a piss at him. Because then, Katsuki would have an actual, justifiable reason to be so angry. Then, Katsuki would have a good explanation to why he had lost control of his temper, to why he had shouted, and to why his entire mood for the day had been spoiled, and to why he felt a burning, consuming sense of rage coursing through him at the mere thought of Deku exhausting himself for *his* sake. So he could communicate with Katsuki, so they could finally have a connection.

As if their connection hadn’t been broken a decade before. As if Katsuki actually *deserved* his effort, after…

He sighed, trying to play it off as a tired huff of breath as All Might placed yet another weight on his back. Katsuki wished Deku was the shitty person he had spent his entire life thinking he was. He wished he had actual, good reason to hate him.

But he didn't. After those two months of hell, Katsuki probably had *negative* reasons to hate Deku, no matter how annoying, stubborn, or inconvenient the soulbond had been.

Which was why his hate felt hollow, in a way. There was no reason for Katsuki to be so angry, and yet, he couldn't seem to get rid of the feeling.

"He's been worried about you".

That pulled the brakes on Katsuki's train of thought and sent a frown to his face.

"*What*?"

"Midoriya shonen", All Might explained. "He's been worried about you. Actually, you're all he talks about whenever I visit him".

Katsuki was glad for the number of boxes piled up on his back which forced him into a bended position that made it impossible for All Might to see his face. Because the face he was making… Well, he didn't even know what it must have looked like, but he knew he didn't want All Might to see it.

"He can tell your behavior towards him is different, but he doesn't know why. He is aware he lost a month worth of memories, but I'm not sure he understands the extent of that. You haven't talked to him about that yet, have you?"

Katsuki stared straight ahead.

"No".

"I see", All Might said, blissfully comprehensive, and he was silent for a while.

Katsuki started to run with the weight on his back, following the route All Might had given him and reaching the assigned mark in record time. He was breathing hard and gasping as All Might removed the weight from his back for his two-minute break.

"Do you think a proper time will come?", All Might asked him out of nowhere, in the middle of the process of removing the boxes.

"What?"

"To tell Midoriya shonen about the soulbond".

Katsuki sighed.

"No".

"Hm".

All Might resumed removing the weights and Katsuki stood up straight, stretching his back. All Might stepped into his field of vision, bearing that look that told Katsuki he was about to offer unsolicited advice.

“There will never be a proper time, Bakugou shonen. But you’ll still have to tell him eventually, before he finds out on his own”, the man said, placing a hand on his sweaty shoulder. “I think he will be very upset to find that he shared such a special connection with you if it comes from someone else’s lips”.

Katsuki glared up at All Might in silence for what felt like an eternity.

“I already have a therapist”, he settled for saying, coldly. If this was any other teacher, Katsuki would have received a scolding or perhaps even a suspension, but, since this was All Might, the man simply sighed with tiredness and the slightest bit of disapproval.

“Yes, I am aware”, he said, starting the process of placing the boxes on Katsuki’s back once again. “I was just trying to help”.

Katsuki ran his next route in silence, and All Might didn’t push the subject. They repeated this process without exchanging a word three more times, until they were done with that specific exercise for the day. Katsuki hunched forwards, leaning his sweaty palms on his knees and panting heavily as All Might put the weights away.

“Look, All Might –“, Katsuki sighed, lowering his head and sounding out of breath. “I get that you’re worried about the nerd. But – I can’t talk to him about *this*. Not until he takes One For All back and recovers his memories”.

All Might frowned.

“Why not?”

Katsuki scoffed as if that was a dumb question.

“Because it would be fucking *weird*. How am I supposed to tell Deku I spent an entire month living with his *soul*? That’s just way too awkward. *And* hard to explain without making it sound creepy and invasive. It’s better to just wait until he remembers on his own”.

“Well, I am confident he will be more understanding than you expect”.

“I don’t expect *anything* because I’m not telling him about it”.

All Might ran an impatient hand across his face.

“Bakugou shonen –“

“How am I supposed to tell him that I’ve got his quirk?”

Silence.

He looked up at All Might with angry, resentful eyes. Bitter eyes, raging eyes, guilty eyes.

“He doesn’t even remember giving it to me. And if you didn’t tell him, which I’m assuming you didn’t, then he doesn’t even *know* he doesn’t have it anymore. *You* know I only took it to save his life. *I* know that, too. But what do you think he’ll think when he finds that out? And

don't –", he added before All Might could interrupt him. "Don't tell me he'll be *understanding* or whatever shit you're about to say. You don't know anything about us. About our childhood".

All Might stared at him.

"You don't know about that messed up stuff I did to him when were kids", Katsuki concluded, not meeting All Might's eyes. "Because he was *quirkless*".

There was silence for a while.

"Whatever happened between you two…", All Might attempted, even though he sounded uncertain. "I'm sure Midoriya shonen will be happy he's alive because of you. I'm sure he'll understand –"

"*No*", Katsuki cut him short, angrier, still not meeting his eyes. "I know you think highly of him, but you have *no idea* what I said to him back then", he sniffed. "The stuff I told him to do".

Take a swan dive off the roof of the building

He raised his head, locking eyes with All Might.

"I don't know what he'll think when he finds out *I* was the one who made him quirkless again. And I don't really want to find out. All I gotta do is wait until he's better".

All Might stared at him for a moment, trying to read him, before crouching down and sitting on the floor with his legs crossed. Katsuki stared at him, not following him suit and staying in his hunched position with an inquiring look on his face.

"So what is your plan?", All Might asked, curious. Katsuki's eyes narrowed.

"I'll wait until he's in shape again and give him his damn quirk back", he provided. "Then he'll remember everything".

"And until then?"

"What?"

"Until he is in shape to regain his quirk, what will you do?"

Katsuki scoffed.

"What I've been doing so far".

All Might bowed his head, sighing.

"That, I believe, is the problem, shonen".

Katsuki stared at him.

“What you’ve been doing so far hasn’t been optimal for Midoriya shonen’s… recovery process”.

A pause.

“Weren’t you the one who said he *needed* me?”, Katsuki asked, feeling a bit too offended by All Might’s comment. He could clearly recall All Might’s words from one of their previous training sessions: *The connection you two created in that month you were together… That was something that I don’t think can be broken. Midoriya shonen needs you. More than ever. And something tells me that you need him, too.*

“I’m not saying he doesn’t need you, shonen. In fact, needing you is probably part of the problem”.

Katsuki stared at him, completely silent.

“More than once, I have found Midoriya shonen either crying or incredibly upset in his hospital room… And though he never tells me the reason, I am sure you can guess what it is”.

Katsuki felt the blood drain from his face and he stood up straight.

“I am not trying to blame you, Bakugou shonen”, All Might clarified after a pregnant pause. “Or to make you feel guilty. But Midoriya shonen is understandably confused, weakened, and, despite everyone who’s been visiting him, *alone*. He has no memory of what truly happened to him and your behavior towards him has been… Inconsistent”.

Katsuki scoffed, squinting at the man.

“The hell is that supposed to mean?”

All Might sighed, giving him an apologetic look. He looked more tired than Katsuki was used to seeing him, and he had grown more so ever since the accident with the villain. It was still hard, getting used to seeing All Might look so bony and slim, but the heavy bags beneath his eyes told Katsuki that the ugly look on his face was not that usual on his weakened form.

“You can’t keep waiting for him to be back in shape, shonen”, All Might advised. “We don’t know how long that will take. If you truly plan to set your differences aside and be his friend, now, you shouldn’t wait until he recovers his memories”.

Katsuki couldn’t help but to glare at All Might at this, several feelings he couldn’t tell apart coursing through his tight chest.

All Might had one of the highest intelligence scores in the history of pro heroes, and there was a reason behind that.

“I can’t tell him about it”, Katsuki settled for responding after a few moments, swallowing dry. “There’s too much to uncover. And… It would be too hard to explain”.

Too hard to talk about.

It would be hard to explain how Deku had grown on him over the course of a month, after a lifetime of animosity. How they had learned how to understand each other. How they had learned to respect each other, and read each other, and work better with each other.

Most things about their newfound relationship had to do with emotions, not actions, and Katsuki couldn't simply explain their bond to the Amnesiac-Deku using *words*. They hadn't learned all that, they hadn't learned how to deal with each other using verbs and nouns and phrases. They had *felt*. They had shared a fucking emotional bond. They had spent one entire month feeling each other's feelings. Katsuki couldn't butcher that experience by trying to describe it – and he didn't think Deku would be able to truly understand it unless he remembered it firsthand.

God, this entire situation fucking *sucked*.

All Might smiled softly at Katsuki, as if he knew a secret that no one else did.

"Though I *do* think you should be the one to tell him, eventually", the man said, "I'm not telling you to do that right now. There is nothing stopping you from being his friend regardless of his memories".

Katsuki stared at him in silence.

"Let's go back to training", he settled for saying.

"I was about to tell you the same".

"Why was he crying?"

All Might was silent for a while.

"You said you found him crying more than once. What was he crying about?"

A pause.

"He's been getting better with the speech and the physical therapy, but he's still… Having trouble. With some things".

Katsuki waited for him to continue.

“He doesn’t like being so dependent on everyone. He feels like he’s a burden, even though all the people who love him have told him otherwise in several occasions”.

Katsuki kept staring straight ahead.

“But I believe what confuses him the most is you”.

Silence.

“He can’t understand what made you care about him, and no one can really tell him about it. Because no one other than you actually knows what truly happened between you two”.

Katsuki kept avoiding All Might’s eyes.

“Sometimes, you are gentle to him, and other times, you are harsh”, All Might pointed out. “He doesn’t understand where your relationship stands”.

A pregnant pause.

“He’s been crying”, All Might concluded. “Because he is worried about you, and there is nothing he can about that at the moment. It frustrates him”.

Katsuki’s face was impassive for a few moments.

He didn’t react with anything other than a muffled sniff and a scowl that didn’t linger too long on his face.

“Oi, nerd”.

“Hmm”.

“Wake the fuck up”.

A sigh.

“C’mon. Wake up”.

“Nngh…”

“I don’t have all night, shitty Deku”.

Izuku blinked his eyes open.

“K-Kacchan…?”

“Yeah. Sit up”.

“W-W-W…W-What…?”

“Shut up and just do as I said”.

“W-What t-t-time…?”

“It’s 10 p.m.”.

“10 p.m.?”

“Thought I was the one with the fucked-up hearing. *Yes,* Deku, it’s 10 p.m. Now get up. And don’t even think of complaining about me waking you up, since you’ve been losing sleep like an idiot out of your own free will for god-knows-how-long. C’mon”.

“T-Thought… Thought you s-said y-you…”

“Yeah, I know what I fucking said. But then I lied in bed and thought about you, trying to read your dumb sign language books with all that hair over your eyes and I couldn’t fucking catch a wink”.

Izuku frowned at him, blushing in the darkness of the room.

“Let no one say your eyesight went to shit because of your dumb hair. And yeah, I saw your books. Now shut up and come with me”.

“K-Kacchan… I c-can’t a-ac-actually…”

“I’m carrying you”.

Without further ado, Katsuki shoved Izuku’s blankets away from him and promptly placed his arms beneath the nerd’s shoulders and knees, picking him up bridal style before Izuku could even make sense of what was happening.

“W-W-W-Wait, K-K-Kacchan!”, Izuku protested, stuttering like crazy, eyes wide and clumsy fingers clinging tightly to Katsuki’s shirt.

(Katsuki tried not to think too much about how that had been *exactly* how Deku’s soul had grabbed him after the villain broke their bond, as he desperately tried to hold on to Katsuki –)

“I know what I’m fucking doing”, Katsuki said, stoic. “Also, you’re so bony you barely weight anything anymore. Is the old hag feeding you properly?”, he frowned, carefully placing Deku down on a chair close to the window. The boy was shaking all over and he looked paler than before, but he managed to stay sat as Katsuki walked behind him.

“Y-Y-Y–“

“Yeah, I got that”, Katsuki interrupted the boy’s nervous stuttering. “Sit still and don’t move”.

“W-Wait, Kacchan –“

Before Izuku could say anything else, Katsuki placed a towel in front of Deku’s chest, grabbed his scissor, and cut through the first lock of hair. It floated gracefully in the moonlight and fell on Izuku’s lap, the dark-green in the dim-lit room a stark contrast against the white of Izuku’s hospital gown.

“If I were you, I wouldn’t fucking move. Unless you’re in the mood for getting a pretty fucked up haircut”.

“D-D-D-Do y-you… D-Do...”, Izuku sighed, frustrated.

“Just *sign*, asshole. I’m not mad about that shit anymore”, Katsuki rolled his eyes.

Izuku hesitated for a moment, but then breathed out a shaky breath.

“*Do you even know how to do this?*”, he signed, not even trying to look at Katsuki, who was standing behind him.

Katsuki scoffed, going back to cutting Izuku’s hair.

“Be honest, Deku: do you really think there’s anything I *don’t* know how to do?”

Izuku frowned.

“*Sing?”*, he signed. Katsuki fumed.

“*What*?! I’ll let you fucking know I have the voice of an angel!”, he growled, doing a special effort not to shout in the infirmary room anymore, especially at that time of the night. Izuku chuckled at the reaction.

“*Just teasing*”, Izuku clarified. “*But shouldn’t you wash the hair before cutting?”*

Katsuki sighed as hard as he could, trying to put as much irritation in the sound as possible.

“Aren’t you an ungrateful little shit. Here I am, cutting your damn hair, and all you think about is a list of things I’m *not* doing”.

Deku started to make the sign for “no” several times over and as urgently as he could, trying to show Katsuki that wasn’t what he meant at all.

“*I was just asking”*, he clarified. “*I don’t know anything about haircuts”*.

“Cleary, from the one you’ve been wearing your entire life”.

“*Kacchan!”,* Izuku protested.

“Sit still, asshat. Cutting wet hair is better, but I’m not about to wash yours. Last thing you need is to catch a cold because you went to sleep with a damp hair. I can cut it dry just fine”, he reassured, going back to cutting the hair.

A while passed in blissful silence, before Izuku shyly signed:

“*Kacchan sugoi*”.

Katsuki snorted, thankful that Izuku couldn’t see the small smirk that appeared at the corner of his lips from where he was sitting.

“Yeah, that’s what I thought, Deku. Stop moving around so much”.

Izuku obeyed.

“Think of this as me making up for being a dick to you earlier”, Katsuki added after a few seconds of silence.

It was hard to see if he was doing a proper job when his only light source was the moon, but he didn’t want to call Recovery Girl’s attention by turning the lights of the bedroom on when Deku should be asleep. Even if someone confronted him about the evident lack of hair in Deku’s head on the following day, no one would have any proof as to what time Katsuki stopped by to do it. Actually, no one would be able to prove it *had* been Katsuki in the first place, but, depending on the final result of the haircut, Katsuki would sure as fuck demand credits.

He did the rest of the job in silence, cutting through Deku’s ridiculously thick, overgrown hair and trying to shape it into something more acceptable. This was something he had wanted to do for a long time, now – something that had been bothering him ever since Deku’s annoying soul was still around to push his buttons, and something that had led him to finding out the truth about the boy’s state.

It felt satisfying, being finally able to cut Deku’s mop of a hair, but Katsuki couldn’t help but to wonder if things would have gone any differently had he never attempted to break into Deku’s room to cut his hair in the first place. If he hadn’t found out the truth.

His rational part knew that this was a stupid stream of thought. If he hadn’t found out, Deku would be fucking dead, because no one would have found the villain in time and UA would have probably suffered from a villain invasion that no one would have expected or prepared for. In a way, everything turned out exactly as it was supposed to, no matter how much “*trauma*” Katsuki had endured in order to achieve that half-happy ending.

As a sea of green curls gradually fell to the floor beneath them like petals, Deku started to look more like Deku and less like a tired, weird, homeless shell of himself. For some reason, that made Katsuki feel like his trip to the infirmary room two hours past his bedtime was worth it. If he tried really hard, aided by the darkness of the room, he could almost pretend nothing had happened to Deku in these past two months. All he had to do was look past the baggy eyes, the tired face, the pale cheeks, the bony form, the lack of muscles, and the shaky limbs. There. Beneath all that, there was his Deku.

Once Katsuki was done cutting the hair, he stepped in front of Deku and held his chin between his thumb and his index finger, tilting the boy's head back slightly so that he could admire his work. Izuku blushed violently, his eyes locked on Katsuki's face.

The haircut was way more acceptable now – no longer an unruly mop of tangled, overgrown hair, but something closer to what Deku's hair used to look like before, if only a tiny bit shorter. Katsuki let go of Izuku's chin and took a step back with a victorious air.

"*How is it?*", Deku signed, curiosity evident in his tired eyes. Katsuki smirked triumphantly.

"How the hell do you think it is? It's *amazing*, dumbass", Katsuki said, grabbing his phone from his back pocket and turning the camera on. He snapped a picture of Deku without any sort of warning so that the boy could see how his hair was looking, and Deku startled at the sudden flashlight.

Katsuki handed him the phone with indifference before Deku could complain about having his photo taken without permission, and as soon as he grabbed the device with his shaky hands and stared at his image, all complaints died at the back of his throat. Izuku stared at the phone screen with wide eyes that gazed upon his new haircut with joy.

A smile immediately blossomed in his chapped lips as if he had never seen something better before, and in that moment, he looked livelier than he had in days, weeks, hell, even in months, two dimples appearing beneath the ridiculous sea of freckles as he turned to stare up at Katsuki with pure happiness in his eyes.

"K-Kacchan, *sugoi*", he managed to whisper aloud this time, with his actual voice, and fuck if that didn't make Katsuki's chest feel a little bit tighter for some reason.

"Yeah, I fucking *know*. No need to thank me", Katsuki said smugly, grabbing his phone back from Izuku's hands. Before the boy could react, and before the huge, shining smile disappeared from his face, Katsuki snapped another picture of him. Upon Izuku's confused look that still bore the hint of a smile, Katsuki explained: "To send to your mom", before shoving the phone back in his pocket as he bent over to pick Izuku back up.

He didn't pick Izuku up bridal style this time, but rather threw the boy over his shoulder like a sack of potatoes and carried him back to the bed, despite his vehement protests and noises of embarrassment and distress. Katsuki didn't want those fingers clinging at his shirt like that again.

He dropped Izuku on the mattress roughly, even though he was subtly careful not to harm him. The boy's face was red with shame and he immediately covered himself with his blanket, not meeting Katsuki's eyes. Katsuki scoffed at the sight and walked away, going back to where he had cut Izuku's hair and crouching down in order to collect the fallen locks from the floor.

"Also, no need to feel fucking embarrassed about it", Katsuki added over his shoulder, annoyed, gathering Izuku's hair into a heap. "Your hair was starting to look fucking ridiculous like that. I did a public service by cutting it".

“I-It was s-starting to… uh… um…”, Izuku frowned, trying to remember the word he wanted to use since Katsuki, who had his back turned to him, wouldn’t be able to see it if he signed it.

“Piss you off”, Katsuki suggested in a deadpan, not looking at Izuku as he grabbed the pile of hair and shoved it into a bag for disposal.

Izuku chuckled.

“Y-Yeah, something, uh, s-something like t-t-that”.

“I figured. You looked like one of those dogs who have so much hair you can’t even see their eyes”, Katsuki scoffed, throwing the bag in the room’s trashcan and stepping closer to Izuku’s bed with a mocking expression.

“K-Kacchan!”, Izuku protested, but it was lighthearted and less stutter-y than he had sounded so far.

“What? It’s just the truth”, Katsuki crossed his arms above his chest. “Like I said, no need to thank me”.

Izuku smiled shyly, but bit his lower lip with a pensive expression. His hands were still shaking a little, probably due to tiredness and weakness, since he was still recovering. He still raised them and signed something that could be translated as:

“*But I still want to thank you anyway*”.

“Don’t break a sweat over it, nerd”, Katsuki rolled his eyes. “You can *thank* me by not sending your stupid ass into a relapse because of this bullshit”, he grabbed one of Izuku’s wrists, analyzing the scar-covered hand before dropping it. Izuku was staring at him with wide eyes. “That’s the last thing anyone needs right now”.

Izuku lowered his eyes, and Katsuki couldn’t really tell if it was from embarrassment, tiredness, of a bit of both. He sighed, knowing he should probably leave Deku to go back to sleep. It was a bit hypocritical to scold the boy for overworking and not resting properly, and then waking him up in the middle of the night on the same day.

But Katsuki knew he couldn’t really leave, not until he dealt with the elephant in the room. The elephant which had been tiny, so far, and mostly ignorable, but that had become huge and obnoxious after he had that conversation with All Might earlier.

Katsuki sighed, his face becoming more somber. Izuku, perceptive as always, even in his moments of weakness, noticed this, and his eyes fixed themselves on Katsuki’s face with curiosity and anticipation.

“Deku”, Katsuki started, the name tasting bitter and sitting heavy in his tongue.

He knew he had Deku’s whole attention, but, for some reason, he couldn’t quite bring himself to continue right away. A tense silence fell between them in the room after Deku nodded to indicate that he was listening.

Katsuki lowered his head, not looking at the nerd. He hated this, but he needed to do it. He needed to face this head on. He needed to be brave, no matter how vulnerable, stupid, or pathetic it made him feel. His head was like a civil war between Doctor Matsuo and his bratty self, the former telling him that it was ok to be true to what he was feeling, even if it was a bit confusing, while the latter told him that Deku looked down on him, and he would use Katsuki's words against him, and he would humiliate him and act like he was better and superior like he always did, like he had been doing ever since they were kids, as if a quirkless loser like himself could ever beat the best of the best.

Quirkless. That word, which had left Katsuki's own lips with such a vicious tone so many times in the past, now felt more like a taboo. Something that made his chest tight and his stomach burn. Something he didn't want to think or talk about.

Katsuki took a deep breath, torn between Doctor Matsuo's reassuring tone and the fake-truth behind his past self's words, when his eyes caught sight of something colorful sticking out from beneath Deku's pillow. Reaching forwards and retrieving the object before Deku could even make sense of what he was doing, Katsuki found that the thing beneath Deku's pillow was the All Might keychain he had given him a while back.

Katsuki stared at Izuku with an inquiring look as he held the keychain in his hand, noticing how red the nerd's cheeks were becoming, his freckles disappearing from view. Deku's eyes were wide and looked almost fearful, as if Katsuki had just caught him red-handed doing something forbidden. He squinted his eyes at the blushing boy.

"The fuck is this doing beneath your pillow?", Katsuki asked, just a bit too aggressively. If he was being honest, he was more confused than angry, which was becoming more and more regular nowadays.

"I – I d-d-didn't – u-uh, w-w-w-wan… I – I – I d-d-didn't…", Izuku stuttered.

Katsuki rolled his eyes with impatience – he knew Deku was having trouble speaking, because spending two months in a fucking coma was bound to have some consequences and apparently, it was pretty normal for people who woke up from such a long time under to have trouble with words. But what annoyed him wasn't Deku's temporary inability to speak properly – it was the fact that he looked like thought he had fucking committed a crime. Plus, Deku *always* stuttered when he was nervous, so Katsuki supposed this was just aggravating his condition.

"Stop stuttering and just *sign*", Katsuki rolled his eyes. "I know I complained that you actually talk to everyone else but me, which I still don't fucking get, by the way, but I'd rather you just sign than stutter like a nervous idiot at me".

Izuku lowered his head, cheeks still burning as he raised his increasingly shaking hands.

"*You're going to mock me if I explain*".

And yeah, that felt like a punch to the gut, but how the fuck could he judge Deku for thinking that? Mocking him was the only thing Katsuki had done for over a decade. It was only right Deku would expect him to keep doing it, especially because he no longer remembered –

Fuck. Katsuki should have bid his goodbye and left right after cutting Deku's damn hair, or he probably shouldn't have come over at all. But if he barged out now things would get even more awkward, and it would honestly feel a bit like cowardice. He sighed, took a deep breath, counted back from ten in his head. *Good thoughts, good words, good deeds.*

"Fine, I won't mock you", Katsuki said, his voice sounding strained. He didn't look at Deku as he said the words and, upon the nerd's silence, he turned his head to meet his eyes.

Deku was staring at him with an uncertain expression.

"*What*? I'm saying I won't fucking mock you", Katsuki repeated, a bit more vehemently this time. "I just want to know why the hell you shoved a fucking keychain beneath your damn hospital pillow, is this some kind of creepy ritual or some shit?", he scoffed.

Izuku's eyes widened even more, if that was possible, and Katsuki looked away again, unable to stare at the green for so long. It still brought up memories that he'd much rather forget.

Izuku bit his lower lip in hesitation, before shakily signing:

"*Promise?*"

Katsuki groaned and threw his head back, sighing heavily before looking at Deku again.

"What, you want me to make a pinky promise or some shit, you fucking baby?", he complained. "*Fine*, I promise. I won't mock you. Not this time, at least", he added, just to feel a bit truer to himself.

Izuku bit his lower lip again, but nodded briefly without looking at Katsuki.

"*I didn't want to bother my friends or my mom, or to look stupid*", Izuku signed. "*But I miss having my All Might merch around. This was the closest I could get to –"*, he suddenly stopped moving his hands. Katsuki squinted, waiting for him to continue, but Deku was still on the bed, staring straight ahead.

"*Go on"*, Katsuki signed back at him. Deku stared up at him with hesitant eyes.

"*My All Might plush"*, he admitted, immediately burying himself on the bed in embarrassment.

Katsuki stared at him, his lips forming a thin, stern line. He had promised Deku he wouldn't mock him, and even though the bratty part of Katsuki's brain was *begging* him to laugh, or to call Deku a baby, or to do all sorts of things that he would probably regret later, Katsuki mustered all of his self-control and stayed very, very silent in a way that crossed the line of being respectful and became downright uncanny. All he did was stare at Deku, whose face was pinker than ever due to his flustering fit and who wasn't making direct eye contact with him.

"Do you want me to get it?", Katsuki asked in a deadpan, face and voice blank of any emotion.

Deku's eyes immediately widened as they locked with Katsuki's.

"W-W-W-What?", he asked nervously, voice raising an octave. Katsuki scowled.

"You fucking heard me, dipshit, you want me to get your stupid plush or not?", he growled in anger and yeah, there went the emotionless façade he had successfully kept for 2.5 seconds.

"N-N-N-No!", Izuku protested, waving his hands around madly. Then, he signed: "*It will make things weird if he sees that*", and yeah, Katsuki had to admit the nerd had a point. Though he would pay actual money to see All Might's face if he *ever* stepped into Deku's hospital room and found the nerd cuddling with a plush toy that had his face.

"Fine, suit yourself", Katsuki said, crossing his arms again and leaning his hip on the edge of Deku's hospital bed. "But you shouldn't sleep with that shit beneath your pillow. It's fucking plastic, nerd; it could end up hurting your head, no matter how thick it is", he said, placing the keychain back on the nightstand where it belonged.

Katsuki expected to hear a muffled chuckle or at least to receive a tiny smile in response, but instead, Deku stared at him with an unreadable expression. Even after a month of sharing all sorts of emotions with the nerd and learning how to read that dumb face of his, Katsuki still had no idea what that particular look meant, and the uncertainty only served to remind him of what he was meaning to say right before he found the keychain.

He sighed. The moment was fucking ruined, but there was no way out of it. All Might had said Deku was getting upset over this shit, and even though Katsuki was currently dealing with a shit-ton of confusing feelings, especially after therapy unburied a lot of shit he had apparently suppressed, he was pretty sure that having Deku relapse because of him would probably have collateral damage. To both of them.

He locked eyes with Deku again, who still had that weird, unreadable expression stuck to his face. He stared at the nerd for a while, trying to put these thoughts into order, before the green overwhelmed him with the start of a flashback and he ended up blurting out:

"Do you trust me?"

Izuku was very silent.

For a moment, Katsuki was sure he wouldn't answer, from the way he was looking at him. But he didn't look away. He kept staring at Deku – though the look could be described as a glare. And then, after what felt like an eternity of silence, Izuku said:

"Yes", and this was the first time he didn't stutter ever since he woke up from the coma.

There was no hesitation in his eyes, and even though "yes" was a simple enough word to be said without stuttering, it still felt like a huge step towards the right direction, in every possible sense.

Katsuki forced himself to maintain eye contact, letting out a breath he hadn't realized he had been holding.

“Then don’t ask me about what happened”, Katsuki said, doing his best to keep anything that resembled pleading from his tone. His eyes were angry, but his voice was softer than usual. “During the time you were comatose. Don’t make me talk about it”.

“K-K-Kacchan”, Izuku tried to interrupt.

“It’s too much”, Katsuki spoke over him, teeth gritted. “It’s too much to uncover, it’s too much to explain, it’s too much –“, he took a deep breath, swallowing dry and glaring daggers at the wall behind Deku’s head. “You wouldn’t fucking understand. And this isn’t me calling you dumb; you know damn well I’m not a sugarcoater. If I say you wouldn’t understand, it’s because you *wouldn’t understand”*.

There was a pause. Izuku was staring at him.

“I know I said I would tell you about this shit when you could give me a proper answer, but –“, he bowed his head down, biting his lower lip as rage coursed through his veins. “I can’t. And I won’t”.

He stared at Izuku, eyes overwhelmed with rage and sadness. Izuku stared back at him, serious, a frown on his face.

“I need you to trust me on this”, he concluded, hating that he had just said aloud that he *needed* something from Deku.

But Deku needed him too, right? So this was ok. He wouldn’t be able to hold it against Katsuki. And if he did, Katsuki had a lot of things that he could throw on his face. It was ok. He could handle being vulnerable this once.

Izuku was silent for a few moments, taking in everything he was being told. Eventually, he signed:

“*I deserve to know*”.

And Katsuki scowled. That was probably what he hated the most about Deku – he *never* quit. He never gave up, he never backed down, he never threw the goddamn towel. And this would probably be the death of him.

Katsuki ran a tired hand across his face.

“Yes, you goddamn idiot, I’m not saying you don’t deserve to know what happened to you during the fucking coma, ok”, he said, impatient, one tired hand on his forehead, trying and failing not to burst with anger. “I’m just saying I can’t tell you yet. You’ll have to wait”.

“*Until when?*”, Izuku signed, a determined, stern, almost displeased look on his face. Katsuki scoffed.

“Until you’re *ready to know*”, he answered bitterly, as one would answer an annoying child who kept asking too many inconvenient questions.

“*And when will I be ready?*”

“I don’t fucking know, Deku, but certainly *not* while you’re still stuck to a hospital bed”.

“*So I must sit and wait until you decide if I am ready or not?”*

“Yeah, basically. So much for trusting me, by the way”.

“*I trust you, but everyone is keeping secrets. I need to know what’s going on”*.

“And you fucking will, you nosy asshole. Just not *now*. You should focus on getting your shitty self back together first”.

“*How can I heal if I don’t even know what’s wrong with me?”*

Katsuki sighed, throwing his head back again.

“*Are you taking out on me?”*

He paused, staring at Deku with incredulity.

“What?”

“*Because I surpassed you. On this”,* he waved his hands to indicate he meant the signing. *“Is that why you won’t tell me what happened, even though you said you would?”*

Katsuki stared at him.

“*Because I surpassed you, and you want to have leverage?”*

He wished he could say his blood was boiling at Deku’s accusation, but the truth was – he didn’t feel anything.

His chest felt hollow as he interpreted Deku’s signing, as he came to understand what Deku was telling him. And the worst part was that he couldn’t even blame Deku for thinking that – he didn’t remember their development. He didn’t remember all the things they had gone through. He didn’t remember any fucking thing, and Katsuki had never given him any reason to think that he *wouldn’t* do something like that. Purposefully hide crucial information from him as some sort of petty revenge.

Deku must have realized the effect his accusation had on Katsuki, because, out of nowhere, he looked guilty. He tried to sign something else, probably to apologize, like the idiot he was, or to try and correct himself, but before he could, Katsuki heard his own voice say:

“I watched you die”.

The world stopped. The only thing grounding them both was the huge moon shining through the infirmary window, steady and constant.

Yeah, ok. He couldn’t leave it like that, now. Fucking great.

“First, when you took the blow for me like an idiot. I thought you were dead. I only found out you weren’t later, but – right then, when I woke up, you were lying there with your eyes open and staring at fucking nothing and I thought you had fucking died. Because of me”.

Izuku stared at him, looking like he had just found an abandoned puppy on the street.

“And yeah, Deku, I know our story is fucked up and there’s a lot of shit I did that – that you –“, he breathed out, angry, looking away. “But I never really wanted you to fucking *die*. Ok?”

He stared at Deku again. The boy looked infinitely, indescribably sad.

“And then you actually fucking flatlined”, Katsuki scoffed.

He stared at Deku, unsure of what his reaction would be, but there was no surprise in his eyes, just a slight uneasiness. Katsuki figured Recovery Girl or his mom must have told him about that, probably to keep him from trying to sneak out of the damn hospital, which he would probably try to do, since he was a dipshit with no self-preservation skills.

“I was there when it happened”, Katsuki added, and *this* time Deku looked surprised, his eyes widening slightly. “And now all I can think about is that shit I told you back at junior high. About the fucking roof”.

Izuku’s face paled a bit and he clearly looked uncomfortable at the subject. Katsuki should have left the haircutting for *after* this shitty conversation, because now Deku’s eyes were out in the open for him to see and to read and to interpret *all* the emotions wobbling in the teary green. And he fucking hated it.

Izuku reached forwards to try and grab one of Katsuki’s hands, but he batted it away before the nerd actually managed to do it.

“Don’t try to fucking act like that’s ok. I know how much it hurt you”.

I can’t tell you how I know just yet. I can’t tell you that you told me so yourself, when you were a ghost, haunting me for a month.

When I could feel the pain I caused you first-hand.

“And I’ve told you time and time again that what’s in the past is in the fucking *past.* I can’t change what I said. I can’t change the shit I did to you. But I honest to fucking god think this whole watching-you-die shit is some sort of messed-up punishment for that crap I told you to do, because I wish I had *never* told you that”.

Izuku stared at him, a few fat tears rolling down his cheeks. His lower lip was trembling and his face was scrunched up in an ugly expression, as if he was about to have a breakdown.

“I was a dick. I was an asshole to you and *none* of the shit I said or did can be justified by that, no matter how fucking annoying you might have been. I was cruel. And after all the shit I’ve seen and thought about, after all the shit that I went through”, he was purposefully vague, since Deku didn’t know about the soulbond, “what I’m trying to fucking do is be

better than that. But having you second-guess me or stare at me like I grew a fucking second head every time I try to do it is fucking *exhausting*".

He sighed heavily and locked eyes with Deku once again.

"So can you stop acting like a fucking idiot for once and let me try to be nice to you without overthinking about this shit?"

He could see the way Deku's Adam's apple bobbed up and down as the boy swallowed dry, and, before he could manage to say or sign anything, his face broke down like a dam and he burst into sobs, shoulders rattling and eyes squeezing shut.

Katsuki let out a breath and closed his eyes, doing his best not to lose his patience.

"Deku. Why are you crying?"

Izuku continued to sob, curling on himself in an attempt not to be too loud, lest he call a nurse's attention. Katsuki sighed and stepped closer to him, sitting at the edge of the bed beside him.

"*Nerd*. Why are you crying?"

Deku kept his head bowed as he continued to cry, but he lifted his shaky hands and signed:

"*I'm sorry for putting you through that",* while his shoulders still rattled from the effort of keeping his sobs quiet.

Katsuki stared at him, not knowing what to say in response to that. That honestly wasn't the answer he had been expecting, but he should have seen that coming.

Deku was really an idiot. A self-sacrificing idiot, a reckless idiot, a heroic idiot.

Katsuki didn't know how to feel about him.

He waited, in silence, until Deku's crying died down and he finally stared up at him again, eyes red-rimmed and swollen with a hidden apology beneath all that. Katsuki sighed.

"Are you done?", Katsuki asked, but even Deku could tell there was none of the usual hostility in his tone.

"S-S-S-or –", Deku tried to say, but before he could finish, Katsuki interrupted him.

"If you apologize to me again, I'm going to smack you so hard you'll be thankful you're already in a hospital".

Deku gave him a tiny smile at that, not quite meeting his eyes.

"Hey. Deku. Look at me", Katsuki called.

Izuku hesitated. Katsuki placed his index finger beneath Deku's chin, lifting his head up gently until their eyes met. He didn't break physical contact as crimson glared deeply into green.

"I'm gonna ask you again. Do you trust me?"

Izuku swallowed dry, his still moist eyes fixed on Katsuki's with a sorrowful expression. But he nodded. And there was no uncertainty in the gesture.

"Good", Katsuki nodded back at him, his hand still supporting Deku's chin up. "Can I trust you not to overwork yourself and not to keep insisting on this damn subject?"

Izuku looked like he terribly wanted to argue, but he eventually nodded, a single reminiscent tear escaping the corner of his eye and rolling down his cheek. Katsuki cleared it away with his thumb and finally let go of the nerd's chin, standing back up.

"Fine. So we're good, then?", he raised an eyebrow at Izuku, who bit his lower lip.

"W-W-We're g-good", he nodded, sounding tired.

Katsuki glanced at the watch on the wall. It was almost 11 p.m.

"I'll let you go back to sleep, then", Katsuki announced, stepping away from the bed. "Feel free to tell your shitty friends that the one responsible for that amazing haircut you're bearing now was *me*".

Izuku chuckled at this, watching as Katsuki walked towards the door.

"K-Kacchan", he called, just as the other boy reached for the doorknob. Katsuki turned on his heels so he could stare at Izuku, who was bearing an uncertain look on his face.

"What?"

Izuku blinked several times, hesitant, before lifting his chin up with confidence and signing:

"*Are we friends now?"*

Katsuki stared at him, his hand still holding the doorknob. He hadn't expected Deku to be so fucking blunt about it – he had been hoping they could leave certain things unspoken. *I don't talk about how watching you die several times messed me up, you don't talk about how I'm acting different towards you now, etc, etc, etc*. But he should have known that, just like Kirishima, Deku was a guy who liked to give names to things, even when, in Katsuki's opinion, they were better off left without a definition.

"If you wanna use labels", he shrugged, feigning indifference. "Then yeah".

The smile that blossomed on Deku's lips was so wide that Katsuki sort of wished, for some godforsaken reason and with all the embarrassment in the world, that he could snap another picture of him without coming off as creepy.

He figured, suddenly, that it was the eyes. Deku's eyes were lively and sparkling and happy, and Katsuki much preferred them to look that way. It was reassuring, in a way, especially because Katsuki knew this was a look reserved for him, and for him only.

"Don't get so excited", Katsuki warned, a teasing, bantering tone on his voice. "I'm not gonna go easy on you just because you're still in the infirmary. I still think you're a shithead".

Deku rolled his eyes, but there was a smile on his lips. Katsuki snorted out a chuckle, and was about to turn around to leave when Deku frowned.

Katsuki bowed his head, breathing heavily before giving Deku an impatient look.

"What is it now?"

Deku hesitated for a split second before sighing and signing:

"*Will you tell me everything? One day?"*

What was left of Katsuki's smile withered in his lips.

"When you're ready", Izuku added, sensing Katsuki's displeasure at the question.

Katsuki sighed. Deku wasn't fucking dropping it, as usual. And Katsuki couldn't really blame him – he was right to want to know. Katsuki just didn't think he could tell him everything just yet.

As much as he hated it, he had also kind of missed Deku's stubbornness.

"Yeah. One day", Katsuki said, purposefully vague. Deku seemed contented with that promise, and settled back down on his bed.

"N-N-Night, K-Kacchan", he stuttered out, before signing: "*Thank you for the haircut"*.

"Like I said, it was a public service", Katsuki scoffed, twisting the doorknob. "City Hall would probably send in a team to trim it down if it grew any longer. Can't have an UA student going around with a Christmas tree for a hair".

"H-Hey!", Izuku protested.

"Good night, Deku. Try to catch some fucking sleep this time, or I'll tell All Might you've been overworking".

Katsuki didn't hear Deku's squeal-y response as he stepped out of the room and closed the door behind him.

He felt lighter that night as he lied down in bed to sleep.

There were still things he was keeping from Deku, and there were still secrets he would have to uncover. But now, Deku knew why he didn't want to talk about it. Or at least, one of the reasons why he didn't want to talk about it.

And even though Deku was a fucking pushover, Katsuki knew that he would probably respect his boundaries. And now, the nerd would also stop fucking worrying about him and focus on his own recovery for once.

So yeah. At least he had bought himself some time until Deku was fit enough to take his quirk and his memories back. And then, Katsuki wouldn't have to explain anything. Deku would remember and feel things on his own, and everything would go back to fucking normal.

Katsuki scoffed. He was at a point in his life where his definition of *normal* was having Deku remember about the month his soul spent sharing a bond with Katsuki in order to go back to his recently-found, better-working routine with the nerd. What a fucking joke.

The emotional strain of having that conversation with Deku sent Katsuki into an easy, heavy sleep that, for once, wasn't plagued with nightmares of dead eyes and echoing calls of his name.

On the following day, he went by himself to the mall, meaning to find an All Might plush toy that was small enough to fit beneath Deku's pillow and that wasn't made of fucking plastic. It took Katsuki some time, but he finally found it, and he didn't even look at the price tag as he took it to the cashier and paid for the damn, stupid thing.

Chapter End Notes

Yes, yes, YES! I know, this took forever. Literally a month, so thank you for your patience and endurance! I was caught by the end of the semester (Brazil be like that) and I had so many papers and assignments and exams and workshops to deal with that I didn't find much time to write. But anyway, watashi ga kita!

This was hard to write. Emotionally, I mean. Like I've said on my twitter, I've upped the number of chapters for this story (again) because I felt like I was rushing Midoriya's recovery a bit and I feel like that's an important part of the story that I shouldn't skip. I stopped trying to determine what the final number of chapters will be because I clearly

change my mind on that every other day, but rest assured - there are at least four more (long) chapters to go.

Bakugou is hard to write, man. I feel like he's grown a lot in my story, so I'm trying to stay true to him while staying true to the plot I created at the same time. Anyway... You know what they say :-) The night is always angstier before the fluff comes! Except this time it's angst coming. Loads and loads of angst. But fluff too. But also angst.

Anyways, thank you as always for reading this and for commenting! Your feedback means EVERYTHING to me. You guys are truly the best and I read everything you send me, even if I don't always have the time to reply. Thank you for your support and your love, I hope this pleased you, and I'll see you next chapter (which will hopefully arrive sooner)!!! <3

P.S.: For those of you who asked - Yes, I'm Brazilian :-)

Chapter 19: A Lot Happens

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

From: Shitty Hair

Hey Bakubro

From: Shitty Hair

Hey

From: Shitty Hair

Bakubro

From: Shitty Hair

Hey Bakubro

From: Shitty Hair

Heyyy

From: Best Friend

What.

From: Shitty Hair

Are you up?

From: Best Friend

No. I'm literally sleeping right now, while I fucking reply to your shitty text.

From: Shitty Hair

Someone's grumpy :-/

From: Best Friend

I'm not grumpy, you're just dumb as fuck

From: Best Friend

Now tell me why the fuck you're texting me non-stop in the middle of the night or else fuck off

From: Shitty Hair

It’s not the middle of the night, it’s 11 p.m. :-/

From: Best Friend

Bye

From: Shitty Hair

Noooo wait

From: Shitty Hair

I wanted to ask you something

From: Best Friend

If you don’t spit it in 15 seconds I’m going back to sleep

From: Shitty Hair

WAIT

From: Shitty Hair

Midoriya is getting released in two days, right? So the guys and I were thinking of throwing him a welcome back party in the common room

From: Shitty Hair

So I was wondering if you could help us with the food? Uraraka and Ashido will take care of the decoration, Sato will bake the sweet stuff and

From: Shitty Hair

Well

From: Shitty Hair

Maybe you could make katsudon? We know it’s Midoriya’s fav and yours is like. Outrageously delicious

From: Shitty Hair

Pretty please?

From: Best Friend

No

From: Shitty Hair

Whyyyy :-(

From: Best Friend

I've got better shit to do

From: Best Friend

Also, the fucker is getting released from the fucking medbay after months. Shoving his ass into a party as soon as he can walk again doesn't seem like the best fucking idea

From: Shitty Hair

Aww are you worried about him?

From: Shitty Hair

Don't worry bakubro we're not gonna overwork him or anything

From: Best Friend

First of all, shut the fuck up, second of all, I seriously doubt you won't

From: Best Friend

I'm already in enough trouble, I won't get myself fucking suspended because you bunch of idiots sent Deku back to the hospital the same day he was released

From: Shitty Hair

Wait, so you're not even coming to the party??

From: Best Friend

I'll give you one chance to guess my answer

From: Shitty Hair

You're so grumpy when you're sleepy

From: Best Friend

You keep fucking teasing me about that and I'll knock your fucking teeth off your mouth

From: Shitty Hair

:-/

From: Shitty Hair

Fine, I'll try it again in the morning

From: Best Friend

Don't

From: Shitty Hair

But bakubroooooooo

From: Shitty Hair

It's Midoriya's welcome back party :-(

From: Shitty Hair

If anyone's gotta be there, it's you!!!

From: Best Friend

Wrong. If anyone's gonna NOT be there, that's me

From: Shitty Hair

I thought you were past pretending you hate him

From: Best Friend

And I thought you were past shoving your nose in my goddamn business

From: Best Friend

Also me not hating Deku anymore doesn't automatically make me stop hating your shitty parties too so maybe try to make some goddamn sense

From: Shitty Hair

You didn't hate my bday party

From: Shitty Hair

You had the time of your life

From: Shitty Hair

You even DRANK

From: Shitty Hair

Which you never ever do

From: Shitty Hair

You'll have fun in this one too I promise

From: Best Friend

Kirishima. Stop trying to convince me. It's not gonna happen

From: Shitty Hair

Ooooooohhhhh you called me Kirishima

From: Best Friend

Yeah. Because I want you to fucking accept the fact that I am not going to this shitty party

From: Best Friend

If anything, I'm totally fucking against it because the shitty nerd should rest, not be up with you lot right after getting cleared out

From: Best Friend

You know damn well he's not out of the woods yet. Am I literally the only one around here with some resemblance of common sense in their damn heads?

From: Shitty Hair

Dude, I know. We all know that. I told you, we're not gonna overwork him or anything. It's not even gonna be big. It's like. More of a welcome back quick reunion that will be over as soon as Midoriya as much as yawns

From: Best Friend

Then why the fuck do you keep calling it a party

From: Shitty Hair

Because we're gonna celebrate so it's a party :-(

From: Shitty Hair

Just come over? Pretty please? You don't even have to cook if you don't want to I was just trying to motivate you

From: Best Friend

How the fuck is asking me to play your servant supposed to motivate me, hair for brains??

From: Shitty Hair

Don’t act like you don’t love cooking

From: Shitty Hair

Or being praised for your cooking

From: Shitty Hair

Or being praised for anything, really

From: Shitty Hair

Or hearing people call your food sugoi

From: Shitty Hair

Or hearing Midoriya call you sugoi (ಠ_ಠ)

Read at 23:16

From: Shitty Hair

Hey

From: Shitty Hair

DUDE come on I was just joking

From: Shitty Hair

Bakugou come back aaaaaaahhhhhhh

From: Shitty Hair

I GOTTA stop doing this every time

From: Shitty Hair

You didn’t even say bye this time :-(

From: Shitty Hair

I’m sorry I wasn’t making fun of you :-(

From: Shitty Hair

Bakugouuuuuu

From: Shitty Hair

Fine. I'll try again tomorrow :-/

From: Kacchan

Heads up. Those clowns are planning to throw you a party.

From: Deku

When I get cleared out?

From: Kacchan

No. While you're still in the fucking hospital. They want to say farewell to your stinky bed.

From: Kacchan

Yes, Deku, when you get cleared out.

From: Deku

Why did you tell me?!

From: Deku

You're spoiling the surprise, Kacchan!!

From: Kacchan

Deku. For fucks sake

From: Kacchan

You're literally getting cleared out now. After staying on that bed for three fucking months.

From: Kacchan

But that's not even my fucking point. It's your fucking life, you decide what shitty decisions you want to make.

From: Kacchan

My point is: I'm not fucking going. So I don't want you to get all disappointed and teary-eyed when you show up and don't see me there yelling 'surprise' like some sort of idiot

Deku is typing…

Deku is typing…

Deku is typing…

From: Deku

Why aren't you going?

From: Kacchan

I've got better shit to do

From: Kacchan

Also, I don't agree with it

Deku is typing…

From: Deku

Oh, ok, I understand

From: Deku

But what is there to agree with?

From: Kacchan

I'm not about to break it down to your dumbass brain why I think heading straight to a party as soon as you get cleared out of a hospital after staying there for three fucking months is a bad idea

From: Deku

Ok, ok, point taken. I still think it's a nice gesture, though…

From: Deku

Will you at least come help me say goodbye to my stinky bed, then?

From: Kacchan

That depends on what time you're getting cleared out

From: Deku

Probably in the morning

From: Kacchan

Then no

From: Deku

Why not?

From: Kacchan

Because I have classes in the fucking morning, in case your shitbrain forgot about that

From: Deku

Well… I suppose you're right

From: Deku

But if you're not going to the party and you're not going to the medbay, when will I see you?

From: Kacchan

On the next day, moron

Deku is typing…

Deku is typing…

From: Deku

Oh

From: Deku

Ok

From: Kacchan

Now I'm off to bed

From: Deku

Yeah, I was going to ask you about that

From: Deku

I mean, it's almost midnight

From: Kacchan

Why the fuck does everyone keep tabs on my fucking sleep time??

From: Kacchan

Get a fucking life!!!

From: Deku

There isn't much for me to do while bedridden to be honest

From: Kacchan

Creepy stalker weirdo

From: Deku

How is it stalking if we're talking right now and I can see what time it is??!

From: Deku

Also it's not my fault you've been going to sleep at early hours ever since we were kids, it would be weird if I DIDN'T know about that

From: Kacchan

Still a creepy stalker weirdo

From: Deku

Are you sleep-grumpy?

From: Kacchan

I will murder you

From: Deku

Ahh you are

From: Deku

Good night, Kacchan ^-^

From: Kacchan

Go to hell, Deku

Katsuki was sitting on his bed, notebook on his lap as he tapped his pen against it unrhythmically. He was having a bit of trouble concentrating on his homework, but it was nothing he couldn't handle. All he needed was some fucking peace and quiet for once, but that didn't seem like an option, since his classmates were being way too fucking loud at the common room downstairs.

(It took him longer than it should have to realize that all he had to do to solve that problem was take his hearing aid off, and he tried not to mentally beat himself being so stupid.)

Still, even with the damn thing off his ear, the assholes downstairs were being so fucking loud Katsuki could still fucking hear them all the way up his bedroom, even with his *one* functional ear. He couldn't help but to wonder how the tired, recovering Deku was coping with having that many people surrounding him right after being cleared out, and then he decided that he wasn't going to waste any more of his studying time on *Deku* (not again, at least. He'd been doing that for months already, and it was about time he stopped).

Deku was his age. He wasn't a stupid, pathetic, sobbing, quirkless kid anymore, who Katsuki mocked for being unable to look after himself. He was a grown ass teen almost in his adult years, and if he was feeling tired or weary or in the need to go to sleep and rest, he could sure as hell go ahead and tell his stupid friends that on his own. He didn't need Katsuki to babysit him or to stand up for him – and Katsuki would be damned if he wanted to do those things.

But who was he kidding? If those entire shitty past months had taught him *anything*, was that Deku's courage was reversely proportional to his self-preservation instincts. His own fucking mom had asked Katsuki to look after him, because she knew her little shit of a son was too much of an altruistic asshole to put his needs in front of other people's. *Ergo*: Deku would probably allow himself to get sickly tired and quite possibly thrown right back into Recovery Girl's arms rather than risk being rude to the nice little friends who had put so much fucking effort on making him a nice little welcoming party. *Fuck* whoever thought that would be a good idea, by the way. They should have taken Deku's complete lack of regard for himself in consideration when they came up with that shitty plan.

(And scratch that: Deku might not be a stupid, pathetic, sobbing kid anymore, but he was straight back to being quirkless again.)

(And only one person was to blame for that.)

Katsuki groaned and grabbed his phone, from which he had turned off vibration and notification alerts due to the sheer number of texts every single one of his asshole friends

were sending him. *You should come down, Midoriya is waiting for you! Come on, Bakubro, don't be such a grump! We miss you! Please come over! We're waiting!*, and all annoying variations thereof.

Katsuki ignored the ridiculous number of unread texts in his inbox and checked Deku's chat instead. There were no new messages from the little shit – the last one had been from when Deku let him know he was getting cleared out and that All Might was helping him back to the dorm, to which Katsuki's only response was "K".

He thought about texting Deku to just get some damn sense into his thick head for once and go to his room to *sleep*, but then he thought about the repercussions of that. The party was *for* Deku, which meant he was the center of it. All of their stupid-ass friends were there, probably surrounding and crowding the fuck out of him (which, quite frankly, was one of the main reasons Katsuki had chosen not to attend), which meant whatever Deku did would be right under a spotlight. And that, on its own turn, meant that if Katsuki texted the asshole, no matter how simplistically, *every single one* of their friends would notice and quite probably comment on it. And Katsuki definitely didn't need to have that sort of attention on the top of everything that was happening in his life.

They probably didn't even know Katsuki had Deku's number or that they texted each other on a daily basis now, and he would rather keep it that way. Not because he gave a shit about what they thought of it, but because it was bad enough Kirishima kept commenting on the new stage of his relationship with Deku. Having the entirety of UA doing the same thing was literally a nightmare scenario. There was a reason why he hadn't gotten Deku's number from any of them – and that was to keep his nosy-ass friend from shoving their noses in his fucking business.

He was kind of friends-and-no-longer-deadly-rivals with Deku now. So what? It wasn't a big deal, it wasn't supposed to be a big deal, and Katsuki didn't want to make a big fucking deal of that. In fact, he was going *out of his way* to prevent it from becoming a big deal – by choosing not to text Deku, by not attending his welcome back party. Trying to improve himself and actually be a kind-of-friend, kind-of-no-longer-rival to Deku was already hard enough to his ego on its own – the last thing Katsuki wanted, or needed, to deal with was a bunch of people asking him questions about it.

I thought you hated Midoriya! What's gotten into you? Are you guys actually friends now? How cute, you care about him! – not even ungodly amounts of anger therapy would be able to prevent him from breaking the teeth of whoever dared to tell him that, and he didn't even know the reason why. All he knew was that this kind of comment made him furious, so he'd rather prevent himself from hearing it altogether than risk being expelled from UA (for real, this time) for misbehaving.

Katsuki lowkey wished he could change the bad things about himself without having every single person he knew make a fuss about it, but that had never happened before and he seriously doubted it was about to start happening soon.

Which was why he had gotten Deku's number from Inko.

He did his best to sound casual about it, but he wasn't entirely sure he had succeeded. In fact, he could never really tell with her – Inko had a mom-way to text people and, because of that, Katsuki could never be sure of what the fuck the woman was thinking or feeling whenever she typed out long-ass texts with correct punctuation marks.

Despite that sense of uncertainty that so rarely loomed in his mind, all he had done was text her the pictures he had snapped of Deku's new haircut, to which Inko replied with a stream of sentences elaborating how prettier and healthier her son looked, and how much she appreciated Katsuki for giving him that haircut. And when Katsuki asked her for Deku's phone number, so that he could "send the nerd the damn pictures before he knocked himself off the bed trying to grab a mirror", Inko gave it to him without hesitation, or without saying anything else.

On the next day, however, she waited until nighttime, which was the only time of the day when Katsuki visited Deku, to leave UA, and she only did so after she thanked Katsuki, and gave him a hug, and deliberately handed Izuku his phone right in front of him, almost as if she wanted Katsuki to know that she knew the real reason why he had asked for her son's number, since Deku had no access to his phone until right then.

Maybe he was just being too paranoid, though.

And Katsuki tried not to overthink about that, because he wasn't even sure if that was what Inko really meant by the gesture, but he couldn't deny that he had found it fucking weird. More than that – he couldn't deny that it had made him fucking uncomfortable. From that day on, Katsuki kept wondering if Inko had told Deku about how he had asked her for his phone number, mainly for two reasons: Deku never questioned him about *how* he had gotten his number and just replied to his first text as if it was no big deal; and Katsuki never sent him the fucking pictures in the first place.

(He kept them on his phone after he sent them to Inko, though.)

Despite that initial stress and ponderations, texting Deku became some sort of habit that flowed naturally into Katsuki's daily routine. None of his friends were ballsy enough to try and question him about who he was constantly texting, and if they did know it was Deku, none of them mentioned it. Which, quite frankly, was a fucking *first*, since all of the assholes kept insisting on questioning *every single* habit-breaker Katsuki bothered doing.

But his point was: texting Deku and having Deku text him was something that had become natural for *them*. Deku was glad for it, since he was still having trouble speaking (especially when it came to speaking in front of Katsuki) and texting made his communication process easier. It wasn't, however, necessarily natural to his *friends*, and Katsuki wasn't about to give those assholes reason to ask him questions or speculate on his and Deku's behalf.

Not that he gave a shit about that, really. He was just thinking about the effect all those nosy questions would have on Deku's already slow recovery, and about his own improvement process, and that was all there was to it. He *didn't* give a shit about what any of his friends thought about any of that. He didn't give a shit about what *anyone* thought. He could be Deku's friend, now, even if he had previously dedicated his entire life to hating and bullying

the nerd. He *could*. It wasn't anyone's business but his and Deku's, and therefore he did not give one single rat's ass about anyone else's opinion.

He *shouldn't*.

Just to prove how little he cared about what other people thought, he decided to text Icy Hot.

(Getting the Half'n'Half bastard's number had been less complicated than getting Deku's. After all, they *had* been training together a lot more often, recently, even after Katsuki made up with Kirishima and went back to training with the boy, too).

From: Bakugou

How long until this shitshow is over?

From: Bakugou

I'm trying to fucking study.

From: Icy Hot Bastard

I'm probably the last person you can blame for being noisy. Generally speaking.

From: Icy Hot Bastard

But Midoriya seems tired. Probably soon.

From: Bakugou

Well. Get this fucking over with.

From: Icy Hot Bastard

I'm keeping an eye on him.

For some reason, that only made Katsuki feel even angrier, even though he knew he shouldn't be. And even if Icy Hot still pissed the hell out of him, they *were* getting along better, now that they agreed to train together. Also, he was probably the one who agreed that throwing Deku a party right now was fucking bonkers. So Katsuki tossed his phone aside a bit too aggressively, grabbed his notebook with more strength than necessary, and tried his best to ignore the still loud sound of laughter and chattering coming from downstairs as he focused on his damn homework.

Less than an hour later, Katsuki noticed the increasingly loud noises of his friends walking out of the elevator two floors below him. Given that he still had his hearing aid off, it was safe to assume they were still being way too fucking loud if Katsuki could hear them all the way from the fourth floor. There was a commotion, loud laughter, words he couldn't really understand, and then…

Silence.

He grabbed his phone and unlocked the screen. There were still over a hundred unread texts on his inbox – most of them from Shitty Hair and Raccoon Eyes –, and the digital clock told him it was just a few minutes past eight. At least his shitty friends had kept their promise of not overworking the nerd, then.

Katsuki sighed, locking his phone again and leaning his head back against the cool wall behind him. His crimson eyes stared straight forward, not focused on anything in particular, as his mind began to wander towards places he finally felt like he could access.

So this was it. Deku was officially back. Well – not back to classes yet and definitely not back to training. But back to the dorm. Back to Katsuki's daily life.

Just *back*.

Because before, Katsuki would have to dislocate himself and go out of his way in order to see the nerd. That was what life had been like for the past two months – the third one didn't count because Deku had been glued to him 24/7 like a shitty ghost parasite. But he had built a routine. If he didn't want to see Deku's shitty nerd face, all he had to do was *not go* to the medical bay. Now… Now he could run into Deku whenever, wherever. That thought sent a spark of annoyance into Katsuki's heart, and he didn't know why.

He didn't know why he had been feeling a lot of stuff recently, if he was being honest.

(He should probably talk about that with his therapist).

Deku would still have to attend his physiotherapy and his speech therapy sessions every single day, and he would only be allowed to go back to regular classes in a few weeks still. Which meant the shitty nerd would be at the dorm, by himself, most of the time. Which meant the shitty nerd would probably figure a way to damage himself even further in no fucking time, because he was no longer under constant supervision. Which meant someone needed to keep a fucking eye on the shitty nerd before he managed to get himself killed – again.

Katsuki closed his notebook and set it away on the top of his studying desk, deciding this was about as much of a nice time as any to lie down and get some rest. He had a long day ahead

of him – he hadn't seen Deku standing up on his own in months that felt like an eternity. He only visited him at nighttime, when the nerd was already set for bed, and the last time Katsuki had seen him on his feet, on his own, instead of lying down like a fucking invalid was –

Stop fucking knocking me down!

I'm just trying to help!

Shut the fuck up!

Kacchan!

He closed his eyes.

He's resistant, this one, isn't he?

Let go of him!

I came such a long way to find him.

I said to fucking let go!

He's such a fighter…

Fuck!

(Matte yo, Deku!)

The back of his throat became bitter with self-loathing and he could feel the way his breathing sped up. He still couldn't believe, to this day, that he had been so easily defeated by such a pathetic D-lister. He still couldn't believe he had almost lost Deku, for real. Forever.

Sometimes, he still thought about the way Deku's body disappeared in front of him. The way it became intangible as the boy sobbed and clung to him and begged him not to let go. The way he had promised Deku he wasn't letting go.

The way the little asshole tried to pass his quirk on to him, and only failed thanks to his shit timing. The way he had ended up taking One For All from him anyway, as Deku sobbed and died in a hospital bed in front of him.

The way he had promised Deku he would tell him all about what had happened. The way he *would* have to stick to his word and do that.

He honestly didn't know how Deku would react. Everything he thought about Deku – everything he spent his entire life thinking about Deku – had turned out to be wrong as fuck. The reaction he expected the nerd to have once he learned that Katsuki had taken One For All from him was to get super pissed and angry and to hate him for all eternity. But hey – Katsuki was the guy who spent over a decade assuming Deku looked down on him and thought he was better than him. So maybe he was wrong about that too, right? Maybe Deku would be

cool about it once he explained everything. Maybe Deku would even go as far as being proud of him – Katsuki could almost hear the little shit's voice, all wobbly and high-pitched, as he praised him for being the new holder of All Might's power and called him *sugoi*.

But, in reality, he couldn't really know how Deku would react. They were no longer fucking connected – he could no longer read Deku's feelings as if they were his own.

And what pissed Katsuki off the most was how much he seemed to care about that.

Once again, for the millionth time over the course of those three cursed months, he wished he could go back to feeling only anger, and nothing more. Other feelings were complicated, and feeling them made his life complicated too. Everything was easier when he could just resort to anger as a way to cope and deal with everything that pissed him off.

Now… He couldn't just force himself to feel angry. He was sure as fuck *still* angry, but there was something else there, now. There was an ache in his chest that refused to leave, that refused to be soothed away no matter what Katsuki did. There was a whirlpool of feelings rotating in his stomach, making his heart race, and his breath stop, and his brain overthink. Sometimes, he got caught up with memories, so vivid and realistic that it seemed like he was living through them all over again. Sometimes, his nightmares got so bad and left him so disturbed that he didn't manage to go back to sleep.

Katsuki hated this. He hated how weak this made him feel. How pathetic, how vulnerable, how despicably helpless. Which was why he didn't tell anyone about it, not even Doctor Matsuo. And this whole internalization process, of course, only served to make his usually bad temper even more sour.

Which didn't make sense for anyone else but him, because he should be *happy*, right? He should be glad Deku was back and recovering. He should be glad.

He convinced himself that all this bad shit would go away as soon as he gave Deku One For All back and the shithead regained his memories. When that happened, Katsuki would finally be able to go back to his normal fucking life, without having to sugarcoat Deku or worry about him or overthink every single thing he was about to tell the nerd. But for him to give One For All back and put an end to that stupid fucking story, Deku would need to: 1. Get better; and 2. Learn that he doesn't have One For All anymore in the first place.

An impulse overcame Katsuki to just get off his bed, climb down the stairs, burst into the nerd's room, and just spit the whole truth on his face. He immediately smothered that thought down, as one single spark of Deku's tear-filled, betrayed eyes erupted in his brain and convinced him that this wasn't a good idea.

Katsuki sighed again, defeated. The feeling, which had always been so rare in his life, was becoming increasingly more common.

Yikes.

He turned on his side, pulled his blanket up to his shoulders, and decided that his only way out was taking baby steps. He was getting fucking tired of the slow pace the events in his life

were taking, but feeling just *anger* about it was clearly no longer an option. He was angry, but he was also… something else.

He didn't know. It made him confused and frustrated and…

And…

He shut his eyes closed and forced himself into a restless night of sleep.

"What the fuck do you think you're doing?"

Deku jumped, not having heard Katsuki's approach. He turned on his heels and paled as his wide eyes met Katsuki's narrowed ones, raising both hands in front of himself as an attempt to show that he meant no harm. In one hand, he held a banana, in the other, a water bottle. Katsuki stayed standing at the entrance of the common area's kitchen, watching as an embarrassed blush made its way to Deku's face.

"K-K-Kacchan! I – I didn't expect a-anyone t-to be up at this – at this – at –", he struggled to find the words.

"Hour", Katsuki completed for him, and Deku nodded his thanks. Before he could stutter anything else, Katsuki took a step forwards, approaching him. "That doesn't answer my question, shitty nerd. It's 5 in the morning", he added, tone coming off as angry. He stared at the banana in Deku's hand, and then back at the boy's face.

"I was h-h-hungry", Deku responded, sounding sincere. Katsuki scoffed.

There was a moment of tense silence in which they just stared at each other in the kitchen, Katsuki angry and Izuku nervous. All Katsuki could bring himself to think about was the way the boy was standing up. On his feet. On his own. And even though his legs were shaking and he looked bonier than Katsuki remembered ever seeing him, he didn't look like he was about to keel over or pass out from the effort.

Deku's hands were still shaking a lot, though. More than usual. More than they should have been. Katsuki vaguely wondered if Deku was putting a special effort on making himself look presentable, if that whole I'm-not-about-to-pass-out-and-hit-my-head-on-the-tiles look was a façade Deku was putting up to prevent Katsuki from scolding him further.

He vaguely wondered if Deku would allow himself to fall apart as soon as no one was looking.

(That was Katsuki's favorite coping mechanism).

Scoffing again and shaking those thoughts off his head (*Deku's not a kid, I'm not his baby sitter, it's not even my business he wants an early snack)*, he entered the kitchen, walking past Deku and heading to the fridge. He opened it, promptly ignoring the feeling of Deku's eyes glued on him, grabbed himself a glass of milk, and closed the door, placing the glass on the kitchen counter.

There was an awkward silence as Katsuki grabbed a cup from the upper cabinet, the way he raised one of his arms in order to do so making his shirt lift up a bit and expose his belly to the chilly air of the room. The hairs of his arms stood up at the feeling, and this reminded him that: one, it was too fucking chilly for Deku to be walking around the empty dorms by himself in the state he was in, and two, Deku was standing with his feet bare on the cold kitchen tiles.

God, he really was a fucking dumb asshole. It was actually surprising how Deku had managed to survive all these years without a quirk. Katsuki basically slammed the cup he had just grabbed on the counter and snapped his head towards Deku, an angry look on his face.

"You should be in fucking bed", he growled, at the same time Deku said:

"W-What about you, w-why are you up?"

They stared at each other.

Katsuki hated the way his chest felt tighter at Deku's question. Soul-Deku knew all about his early morning routine. He knew Katsuki was an early riser. He'd never question Katsuki's reasons for being at the kitchen at such an hour, because *he'd know*.

This Deku, on the other hand, was staring at him with wide eyes, embarrassed for having spoken at the same time as him and curious about Katsuki's reasons. Katsuki was suddenly overcome with a deep will to punch the nerd in the face and pull him into a hug, all at the same time, because he hated him for not remembering everything, and worried about him for being such a reckless son of a bitch.

The thought of Deku getting himself killed over his stupid-as-fuck altruism, which Katsuki had spent his whole life doubting and was only now coming to terms with, however slowly, made his stomach churn. His paranoid brain made him wonder if Deku was being reckless on purpose, just to shove on Katsuki's face how wrong he had been for believing he was being looked down on all those years.

Half of him knew that thought wasn't rational, because Deku wouldn't risk getting sick just to make a fool out of him, but the other half of him that was petty, angry, and still childish, sent him tightening his hands into fists and growling low at the back of his throat. Whatever the truth was, one fact didn't change – Deku shouldn't be down there on this cold, by himself, barely a day after being cleared out of the hospital.

Katsuki knew that if he opened his mouth to speak, he would end up saying something he regretted – either a snarky, rude, aggressive response that was bound to send tears to Deku's

wide, innocent eyes, or something that would result on Deku asking him a lot of questions he knew he couldn't answer just yet. So instead of bothering to offer the nerd a response, Katsuki poured himself a glass of milk, downed it in one series of large gulps, set the glass down, put the milk back into the fridge, grabbed one of Deku's forearms, and dragged him towards the elevator, all the while avoiding the nerd's eyes.

"K-K-Kacchan!", Izuku exclaimed, surprised by the quick turn of events.

"Like I said, you should be in fucking bed", he grunted, not looking at Deku. He pressed the elevator button and waited for it to arrive, never letting go of Deku's arm, which was cold to the touch and had grown even more shaky.

"B-But –", Deku tried to say, but Katsuki interrupted him.

"The fuck do you think you're doing down here, in this cold, without even putting some fucking socks on? Are you *trying* to get yourself back to the infirmary? Is that what you want, shitty nerd?", he finally turned his head to glare at Deku, making sure his anger was explicit in his eyes.

Deku blinked at Katsuki, frowning, before shaking his head no.

"N-No, w-what, of course not", he said, surprisingly coherent, at the same time the elevator opened and Katsuki shoved him inside, following right after him.

"Could have fooled me", he scoffed, pressing the button to Deku's floor. His bedroom was on the second floor, but Deku was in no condition to climb the stairs, even if it was just one floor up, and carrying him would be too much of a stretch in their newfound relationship. Carrying Deku to a chair in order to cut his hair while he was still in the hospital had already felt like it was too much; Katsuki wasn't about to give Deku any reasons to overthink by taking him bridal-style to his room.

Why the fuck was he thinking about carrying Deku bridal-style to his room, anyway? Katsuki shook that thought off his head with anger.

"K-Kacchan –", Deku attempted, noticing the way Katsuki was avoiding looking at him.

"I'm tired of this bullshit you keep pulling", Katsuki cut him off with annoyance as the elevator door opened. They both walked out, Izuku being basically dragged by Katsuki across the hall, and the angry boy lowered his tone of voice down to a whisper in order not to catch the attention of the sleeping friends that shared the dorm floor with Izuku. "I'm telling All Might if I catch you doing something like this again".

"Like what?", Izuku whispered back at him, looking genuinely confused and just the slightest bit irritated. They stopped in front of his bedroom, but instead of entering it, the boy simply turned to Katsuki and glared up at him, leaning back against his closed bedroom door. Katsuki's hand was still squeezing his forearm. "G-Grabbing something to eat?", he asked, almost annoyed by Katsuki's reaction.

“Yeah”, Katsuki scoffed. “Because that’s the *only* reason you went down to the kitchen at 5 in the morning”.

“Why else would I go to the kitchen?”, he waved the banana at Katsuki’s face as if to prove his point, but his argument was completely killed by how bad his hand was shaking as he did so.

“Because you’ve been stuck to a bed for so fucking long you couldn’t wait to go back to walking and going around your damn business on your own”, Katsuki pointed out.

From the way Izuku’s face fell and he looked away, cheeks tinging red, Katsuki knew he had guessed it right – like he always did.

“But guess what, asshole”, he continued, angry. “You may be off the medbay, but your body’s still weak as fuck. Walking on your own to the coldest place in the damn dorm with your feet bare and not even a coat on at 5 a.m. is not doing your fucked up immune system any favors, and I’m not your fucking baby sitter”, he let go of Izuku’s arm and twisted the doorknob of his bedroom, pushing it open and all but shoving the boy inside. “So you pull that shit over again, I’m telling All Might. I’m fucking done with your reckless-ass behavior. Take care of your *fucking* self, for fuck’s sake”.

Before Izuku could say anything, Katsuki shut the door on his face and walked away.

So… Not exactly how he had imagined their first reunion would go.

From: Deku

You still haven’t told me why you’re up at this hour

From: Kacchan

And guess what: I won’t

From: Deku

And how is that fair?

From: Kacchan

It’s not

From: Deku

You know, you didn't need to drag me all the way back to my room. I wanted to grab myself another banana

From: Deku

And now I'll have to go all the way down there again

From: Kacchan

Haha. You're hilarious

From: Deku

I'm not joking

From: Kacchan

Yes you are

From: Kacchan

Because you know I wasn't fucking bluffing about telling All Might you're a dumb piece of shit

From: Deku

All Might would encourage me to eat all the potassium I can get my hands on

From: Kacchan

At five a.m., on your own, with no coat or socks on. Sure

From: Deku

It's not even that cold, Kacchan

From: Kacchan

Then why the fuck were you shaking so much huh

Deku is typing…

Deku is typing…

Deku is typing…

From: Deku

I wasn't

From: Kacchan

Deku. Do me a favor and go the fuck back to sleep. I got better shit to do than argue with you

From: Deku

I'm not arguing!

From: Deku

I just asked you a simple question and you're refusing to answer it

From: Kacchan

I wake up this early every day. It's not a big fucking deal and it's part of my work out routine

From: Kacchan

So just mind your own business

Deku is typing…

Deku is typing…

Deku is typing…

From: Deku

It's just…

From: Deku

I don't know how to say it

From: Kacchan

Then piss off

From: Deku

You looked tired, Kacchan

Katsuki scoffed.

From: Kacchan

Probably due to the fact that it's 5 in the fucking morning

From: Kacchan

Also, so did you

From: Deku

Yes, but I was in a hospital for three months

From: Deku

You looked like you could use some rest. Do you really have to wake up so early?

From: Kacchan

Yes. And now I'm going to work out and head to class so stop texting me

From: Deku

Ok…

Deku is typing…

Deku is typing…

Deku is typing…

From: Deku

Can we talk later, though?

From: Deku

It's ok if you're busy, I just wanted to ask you something

From: Deku

It could be over text, if you want

From: Kacchan

Fine

From: Deku

Have a nice day, Kacchan ^-^

From: Deku

Oh, remind Iida-kun to take notes for me!!

(Read at 5:45 a.m.)

“Dude, you missed the party. It was *so cool*”.

“Yeah, man. You really did miss it”.

“If any of you losers keep telling me about this shit, I’m gonna go eat lunch by myself”.

“Midoriya was so happy! He teared up when he saw the welcome sign –“

“I’d be fucking impressed if he *hadn’t* teared up”.

“ – and he downright *cried* when we gave him that special edition All Might action figure”.

“What era was that?”

“Silver, I guess”.

“No, it was gold”.

“Dude, that wasn’t gold. It was too cheap to be gold –“

“It was a promotion!”

“Still, the gold ones are way more expensive”.

“And we all helped with the money, so even if it was gold –“

Katsuki stood up, grabbed his tray of food and walked away from the table. He ignored Kirishima’s and Mina’s loud, squeaky plea for him to come back and instead took the seat beside Jirou, who was sat relatively far away from the noisy group of friends, without asking for her permission or excusing himself. The girl looked up at him and Yaoyorozu, who was sitting beside her and was in the middle of telling her something, did the same.

“Of course, Bakugou, you can sit with us, no problem”, Jirou told him sarcastically and in a deadpan.

“I know”, he said simply, not looking at her or at Yaoyorozu as he went back to eating. Jirou rolled her eyes but didn’t offer any further resistance, turning back to Momo and continuing the conversation they had been having before his arrival.

“So, I did send him the playlist, but I’m not sure he’s listened to it yet. There’s a lot going on right now, he’s probably trying to rest and catch up with everything he missed”.

“I’m sure he’ll love it”, Yaoyorozu smiled. “I certainly loved mine. You have a talent to figure out people’s music tastes!”

“Well, I hope Midoriya thinks the same”, Jirou shrugged, a bit embarrassed by the praise. “Blasty here sure liked the one I made for him”, she nodded at Katsuki, trying to include him in the conversation. Katsuki spared the pair of girls a disinterested glance before shrugging, legs crossed on his seat in a rather rude manner and shoulders hunched forwards as he chewed his food.

“It was ok”, he said.

“You know I can see how many times you pressed play, right?”, Jirou raised one teasing eyebrow at him. “I’m the creator of the playlist”.

Katsuki scoffed.

“Well, now that’s some intrusive shit”.

“I think what he means to say is ‘thank you, Jirou, for making me such a nice, close-to-home playlist that helped me relieve some of my emotional constipation’”, Jirou teased, earning a chuckle from Yaoyorozu and an angry scowl from Katsuki.

“Fuck off”, he growled.

“Well, I have to go now”, Yaoyorozu announced, readying herself to stand up. “I need to finish that Quirk Theory assignment. I’ll see you later?”

“Sure”, Jirou nodded, turning back to her unfinished plate of food. “See ya”.

“Bye, Bakugou-kun”, Yaoyorozu said with a polite smile, picking her tray up.

“Hm”, Katsuki nodded at her, still eating. As soon as the girl was out of view, Jirou sighed and turned to him, chewing.

“So, everyone’s talking about the party, huh?”

“Yeah. And if you plan on doing it too, I’ll find another table to eat at”, was his grumpy response.

“No, all right, I get it”, Jirou shrugged. “Just checking if my guess was right”.

“What guess?”, Katsuki scowled at her.

“Well”, she shrugged again, taking another bite of her food. “You never sat with me before”.

“What? Of course I have”, Katsuki scoffed.

“Not for lunch”.

“You got earwax up your brain? *I’ve had lunch with you before*”.

“Nope”.

“You’re fucking crazy”.

“When was it, then?”

Katsuki thought for a moment.

“See? Told ya”.

“Shut up, Ears”.

“I just think it’s kind of crappy you only ever look for me when you get fed up with your other friends”.

Katsuki stared at her, frowning. He was about to ask her what this sensitive crap was all about, but then he spotted the shit-eating grin that had painted the girl’s lips.

“You’re a shithead”.

“I’m just teasing you, Explodoking”.

“Fuck off. I’m the one who gives people nicknames”.

Jirou chuckled, and then turned to look at him.

“How’s the hearing aid doing? Kirishima said you got a new one from that girl from the Support department”, Jirou asked casually. Katsuki sighed, but he was glad at least *someone* was talking about something that didn’t involve shitty fucking Deku.

“It’s fine”, he shrugged. “It’s lighter, it doesn’t hurt my ear, and it doesn’t give me any feedback. So far, so good”.

“Hm”, she nodded. “That’s good. I hate feedback”.

Katsuki stared at her.

“Sometimes it happens when I’m using my quirk”, she explained. “It’s not the same way as it happens to you, probably, but it still sucks. I can relate”.

“Tch”, was all Katsuki offered as a response.

They continued to eat in silence after that, and Jirou finished her food before Katsuki did. She grabbed her phone and scrolled randomly on social media until he was done, clearly only lingering by in order to keep him company.

Once Katsuki resumed eating, he grabbed his and her trays, making Jirou stare up at him with a look that could be described as surprise. He stood up and stared down at the sitting girl with a serious, almost pissed-off look, but one that had silent gratitude clearly etched underneath it.

“Just so you know, I might start having lunch with you more often. I’m not a fan of listening to shit talk while I eat like those dumbasses do, and they’ve been driving me fucking crazy these past days”, he announced in a deadpan, nodding at Kirishima’s table. Jirou stared at him with a similar deadpanned expression.

“Are you asking for my permission?”, she raised a teasing eyebrow at him, the little shit. Katsuki scoffed and scowled at her, his look turning into a glare.

“No, I’m giving you a heads up”, he retorted, annoyed. “Don’t want you whining at me next time I show up”.

“All right”, she shrugged. “Consider myself heads upped”.

“Fine”, he grunted, and without bidding his goodbye or even sparing her another look, he turned on his heels and headed to the cafeteria’s exit door.

“Oi, Bakugou!”, Kirishima called after him as he walked by, still surrounded by their group of loud friends. “We doing that training thing later?”

“Yeah”, Katsuki responded without looking at him, placing the trays on their proper place and heading back to his dorm.

From: Deku

Are you off to bed already?

From: Kacchan

What does it matter to you

From: Deku

It’s just I said I wanted to talk earlier today

From: Kacchan

And you said it could be over text, so spit it

Deku is typing…

Deku is typing…

Deku is typing…

From: Deku

Ah, it wasn't a big deal anyway. Never mind ^-^

From: Kacchan

Oh, fuck off

From: Deku

What?

From: Kacchan

I fucking hate it when you do that

From: Deku

Do what?

From: Kacchan

Play hard to get so I have to beg for you to tell me shit

Deku is typing…

Deku is typing…

From: Deku

When have I ever done that, though?

From: Deku

It's not like we have lots of conversations, Kacchan

Katsuki gritted his teeth in frustration. Fucking amnesiac Deku.

I told you that because of this shared-feelings bullshit, you'll have to tell me when you feel like shit, because I'm not about to be all miserable and moping because your stupid ass was too much of a wuss to tell me something's wrong. I ain't repeating myself, so just tell me what it is so we can fix it.

It's nothing.

Fine. See if I fucking care.

From: Kacchan

If you're not gonna say what you want to say, then I've got better shit to do

From: Deku

All right

Katsuki set the phone away and refused to think about what Deku's unusual acceptance meant.

Katsuki had so much shit to do, he didn't even notice as the week came to an end and another one began.

Just because shitty Deku was out of the hospital and getting better at the whole speaking thing, that didn't mean Katsuki would let his guard down – which resulted on him dedicating several hours of his days to his sign language classes. That, added to the exams that were coming up, were a bit too time-consuming for him to focus on anything else, with the sole exception of training with Kirishima and (sometimes) with Icy Hot. When Deku questioned him about his unusual absence – because of course the spoiled little shit would get used to seeing Katsuki *every day,* as their hospital-routine had allowed him to –, Katsuki didn't bother making up excuses: he just told Deku he was busy studying, and that was all there was to it.

Of course, the reason for his absence *was* the studying, but he couldn't deny he was also feeling a bit awkward. It was one thing to see Deku every day when he was stuck to a hospital bed in Recovery Girl's infirmary – it was another entirely different thing to visit Deku in the nerd's bedroom or in the common room, where everyone could see them or eavesdrop on their conversation. Not that they had anything to hide – but Katsuki was a person that valued his privacy and didn't want any of his asshole friends to go around spreading gossip around them.

The easiest solution was to invite Deku up to *his* bedroom, but: 1. Katsuki knew things would be different from when Ghost-Deku was there, which was only bound to make him feel even

more pissed off than he already was; and 2. He didn't want to ask. Because that would sure-as-fuck be an awkward conversation, and he didn't want to think about the consequences of that.

If he was being honest, he didn't really want to think about Deku that much. It always sent his brain on a spiral that resulted on a dead-end, and it left him more frustrated than anything. All he could do was wait, no sort of direct action would have any positive outcome, and just sitting around with his arms crossed doing nothing was driving him crazy. Katsuki absolutely hated this, he was a man of action. He wished he could just straight up go and tell Deku everything, the consequences be damned. At least that would be one less weight on his shoulders.

He sighed. It was Monday again, and he had an exam to attend to.

He was one of the first to finish it, which meant he was allowed out of the room and back to the dorms early. That gave him extra time to stroll his way back and wonder, once again, about how the fuck he had managed to get himself knee-deep in such a shitty situation.

Maybe he had been a bit of an asshole the past week. He knew how much Deku appreciated his stupid little visits, and then Katsuki had stopped doing them altogether. It wasn't his fault Deku was out of the hospital – if anything, he was fucking glad for it –, but he could have made an effort. Everyone kept asking him about it, All Might had hinted more than once that seeing him made Deku's day, and if he had to be honest with himself, he sort of missed the nerd's company.

What?! It wasn't his fucking fault. He had gotten soulbound to the piece of shit, it would be weird if he *didn't* miss him – especially after spending months seeing him every single day. This was an aftereffect of the quirk, probably.

Later that afternoon, after he was done training with All Might (who had been avoiding even mentioning Deku's general existence around Katsuki ever since their last conversation), Katsuki arrived at the dorm building, dripping wet from sweat, clothes clinging to his exhausted body, the electricity of the unused quirk he was carrying against his will making the tip of his fingers tingle and twitch. And as he passed by the common room, he spotted him: Deku, laughing loudly, throwing his head back and exposing his neck, leaning heavily on Icy Hot, Round Face curled closely to him on the couch. Even from the distance Katsuki could see his stupid dimples, and the way his face was lit up with happiness. He looked less tired than when Katsuki had last seen him, standing shaking and sockless at the kitchen in the middle of the night. And, for a split moment, Katsuki went all the way back to hating him again, only to realize a second later that the hollow feeling in his chest was much more complex and bittersweet.

He went back to his room without stopping to talk to any of the people at the common room, and none of them even noticed Katsuki walking by.

“You seem angry”.

“Well, that’s what I’m fucking here for”.

“Jar”.

Katsuki sighed, fishing a couple coins and placing them in the swear jar without a second thought. He glared angrily at Doctor Matsuo’s feet.

“Would you like to tell me what’s troubling you?”

Katsuki stared up at her with an annoyed look.

“You know what it is”.

“Do I?”

“Well, of fucking *course* –“, he cut himself short with an angry sigh, looking away from her and placing another coin in his almost-full jar. He stayed silent.

She studied his face for a while, patient. When Katsuki didn’t continue, she broke the silence.

“Is this about Midoriya-kun?”

Katsuki rolled his eyes, feeling like this response was a bit childish but not caring about it enough to stop himself. He was allowed to feel a bit petty, if he was being honest, at least in these sessions, where he had to be fully sincere.

“I see”, she sighed upon his everlasting silence, shifting positions on her seat. “Did you bring your anger list for the week?”

Katsuki scoffed, taking the crumpled paper from inside his jacket and handing it over to her. The therapist reached forwards and took it, reading the list carefully and with attention.

She was silent for a while, taking in everything Katsuki had written. He knew his list was enough to tell her why he was in such a sour mood, so he simply waited, staring at his swear jar and wondering how much money was in there already.

“You’ve written ‘amnesiac Deku’ a lot”, she commented eventually, a curious note on her calm tone. “What does that mean?”

“You know what that means”.

“Do I?”

“Stop fucking *doing* that”.

“Doing what?”

“Saying ‘do I?’ as if you actually didn’t fucking know. We’ve been doing this long enough”.

“Precisely”, Doctor Matsuo nodded. “We’ve been doing this long enough. Which means you already know you need to be honest and open with me if we plan on dealing with your issues”.

“It doesn’t matter if I’m fucking honest with you about this or not”, he said, already placing another coin into his jar already. “This is an issue you can’t fix, so it makes no damn difference”.

“Of course it makes”, she said, placing his list aside and leaning forwards on her seat. “What makes you think this is a problem we can’t work on?”

Katsuki scoffed, shaking his head.

“What, you’re gonna magically make shitty Deku remember everything that happened?”, he asked, bitter. “You can’t. *I* can’t. I gotta wait”.

She stared at him. He glared at her.

“Wait until what?”, she asked.

Katsuki let out a shaky breath, angry. *Until he can take One For All back,* he thought, but he couldn’t tell her that. That was Deku’s and All Might’s secret, and if Katsuki told her about it, not only would he break their trust, but he would put her – and them – in danger. Well. *More* danger.

Which was why this situation sucked and was becoming too much for him to handle. He couldn’t talk to any fucking one about it, because there were only two people who knew about One For All – Deku, whose reaction to being quirkless again was fucking unpredictable and something Katsuki didn’t want to witness, and All Might, who was a loser for Deku’s puppy eyes and would always pair up with the nerd no matter what. If Katsuki went up to him and told him he wished Deku would just remember already, All Might would tell him to just tell the nerd the truth, which was an option he had already discarded and that didn’t fucking help him with anything. Long story short, he was on his own in this one until shitty Deku got buff again.

~~(He forced himself to stop thinking about how buff Deku had gotten before the accident)~~

“Until he remembers”, Katsuki provided, not meeting her eyes.

“How can you be sure he will remember?”

Katsuki sighed. She couldn’t know. He couldn’t tell her.

“I don’t want to talk about this”, he cut her short, one of his legs bouncing.

She studied his face for a while, attentive, before sighing and leaning back against her seat.

“All right. What would you like to talk about?”, she asked patiently. Katsuki’s hands tightened into fists, and he felt frustration overcome him yet again.

Because all he could think about anymore, all his thoughts revolved around, was shitty Deku and his stupid recklessness and his recovery process. And he couldn’t tell Doctor Matsuo about that, because the conversation would inevitably reach that unspeakable point where she asked him about amnesiac Deku and Katsuki *could. Not. Talk. About that.*

She seemed to sense his frustration and the anger that inevitably accompanied it, because she said:

“Bakugou-kun, is there something you’re not telling me?”

And that was what finally made Katsuki snap.

Months of frustration climbed their way up his throat and before he knew better, he was on his feet, kicking his seat away and just trashing everything he could get his hands on. He didn’t know if he was using his quirk or if it was just his bare strength, but all he knew was he was fucking *done*. He had never asked for this, he had never signed up for this, he didn’t want to be so intrinsically involved with Deku, he never wanted to get so attached to him, and yet here he was, ruining his therapist’s office because the shitty nerd didn’t remember anything about him and the time they had spent together and there was no one he could talk to about it without fucking putting lives at risk. He was alone. He was completely fucking alone on this, and he didn’t have to be, because all he had to do was fucking tell Deku. And yet, he was too much of a coward to do so.

He didn’t even understand what he was so afraid of. So what if Deku hated him? His life would be a lot fucking easier if Deku hated him. He wouldn’t have to worry so much, or to think so much about him. All he would have to do was wait until the asshole got fit enough to take his quirk back, and then their connection would be over. No more sleepless nights, no more nightmares, no more anxiety. God, he wished Deku hated him. He wished Deku hated him.

He wished he hated Deku.

Despite everything you did to me, I still love you. I always have.

And that was it, wasn’t it? At the end of the day, ever since they were fucking four, Deku’s love and unfaltering praise had always been a constant in Katsuki’s life. The only constant in his life anymore, because everything seemed to have changed. *He* had changed. So much. So hard. If Deku hated him – if Deku started hating him –, he would lose his footing. He would lose *every* resemblance to normalcy. He had attached himself to Deku’s love like an addict, it was the only thing that could ground him anymore. Which was fucking ridiculous, if he had to be honest, because Katsuki had never needed anyone.

He had *never* needed anyone. He had always fended for himself, on his own. And the fact that now he felt like he needed Deku, the guy who he fucking told to *kill himself*, made him

feel weaker and ridiculous. Vulnerable. *Pathetic.* And the worst part was that Deku didn't even know – he was completely clueless.

Katsuki hated himself for having fallen so low. For letting himself depend on someone. It felt like his soul was still connected to Deku's, but Deku's was no longer connected to his. And he *missed him*.

He hated it, but he missed him. He longed for him. And he *hated it*.

He had fallen on his knees in the middle of Doctor Matsuo's office. His armchair had fallen down, the desk that sustained his swear jar and a plant pot was broken, the jar itself was destroyed, the money was scattered to the ground. Everything was a mess. Even the tapestry in the office was askew, scorched at the edges. The only thing Katsuki hadn't broken was Doctor Matsuo's armchair and the woman herself.

He stared up at her, panting, his tongue dry in his mouth. He became aware of the fact his face was twisted up into a feral scowl and relaxed, untightening his jaw and his fists, allowing his shoulders to slump. Doctor Matsuo was looking at him, but there wasn't a single trace of fear in her features – only her everlasting patience, as if she was waiting for Katsuki to finish his fit in order to speak.

"Are you done?", she asked him, sounding like she sincerely wanted to know. Katsuki swallowed dry and sniffed, nodding. The therapist nodded back.

She got up from her seat and crouched down on the floor in front of Katsuki, placing a comforting hand on his shoulder.

"You're not obliged to tell me everything", she told him patiently. "But keeping it to yourself will always do more harm than good. This", she gestured to her destroyed office, "is what happens when you let yourself get overwhelmed. When you let things pile up, until they become more than you can handle".

He sniffed again, trying to keep a strong façade.

"I don't need to remind you that I'm here to help you", she continued. "That you can trust me. And that everything you say will never leave this room. But that doesn't mean you have to talk about matters that make you uncomfortable".

She sighed, looking away for a moment as if trying to find the right words.

"However", she sighed. "Midoriya seems to be the one subject you always avoid talking about, and he also seems to be the most constant and primary source for your anger. And this is clearly taking its toll on you", she gave him a serious, concerned look. "Avoidance is rarely ever the best option, Katsuki. By facing your problems face-first, you can take them on. By running away from them, you allow them to become bigger than you. Stronger. Until one day, they catch up with you and swallow you whole".

Saying this, she got back to her feet, staring down at Katsuki's kneeling figure.

“I don’t expect you to talk about him if you don’t want to. But I need you to think about what happened here today, and think about what I just told you. No matter how amazing you are, not even you can outrun your own emotions”.

She grabbed her purse and headed for the door. Katsuki watched her go.

“Another lesson you can learn from this is that your messes don’t clean up after themselves”, she told him, reaching for the doorknob. “If you screw up, you fix it”.

She opened the door and walked out, leaving Katsuki alone in the middle of the destroyed office.

She was right. This was his mess, so he would fix it. He only hoped this anger fit shit hadn’t gotten him in trouble with the UA board again. What if Doctor Matsuo told them he had wrecked her office? What if he finally got his ass expelled again, and threw his career on the trash *again* because of Deku *again?*

A noise called his attention as he collected the broken pieces of the jar, and looking over his shoulder, Katsuki found Doctor Matsuo holding a broom and a shovel. She handed the broom over to him, and Katsuki grabbed it after just a second of hesitation.

“Fixing your screwup doesn’t always mean fixing it alone”, she told him patiently. Instead of waiting for a response, Doctor Matsuo walked past him and placed the fallen armchair back in position. “I’ll take care of the table; you swipe that glass away and collect the money. And don’t even think about taking some of it back – I’ll know if you do”.

For the first time in weeks, Katsuki felt a genuine smile climb to his lips.

And for the first time in forever, even if he couldn’t tell Doctor Matsuo everything he wanted to, he didn’t feel so alone.

Unfortunately, that didn’t mean everything was fixed.

But the anger fit and the destruction of Doctor Matsuo’s office (“*You know, I knew this was going to happen, sooner or later. It’s normal for patients to have angry fits during anger management therapy, it was only a matter of time. Think of it as a peak moment – now that we’ve gotten past it, it means we’re closer to a recovery”)* didn’t necessarily mean he was suddenly ready to tell Deku everything. If anything, it only made him think *more* about his relationship with the nerd – and it helped him reach a rather unpleasant conclusion.

He wanted to be a hero. That was the primary certainty in his life, the one that had always accompanied him – the one that was even more of a constant than Deku's admiration. And, because of Deku, Katsuki had risked his hero career. *Twice*. Probably even more times than that, times that he wasn't even aware of. And that couldn't keep happening.

He felt like he was waking up after spending months stuck in a dream. He had allowed sentiment and emotion take the best of him, he had allowed his brain to mirror Deku's mixed, confusing feelings and in turn make his own feelings mixed and confused. But there was one thing he was sure of – he wanted to be a hero. And he needed to stop allowing Deku to get in the way of that – whether it was by surpassing him or by consuming every thought he had.

Of course, Katsuki was well aware he couldn't just cut the nerd off his life completely – he could almost feel the ghost of Deku's pain from being isolated throbbing in his chest. But he also couldn't keep risking his chance of becoming a pro because of him. He couldn't let himself lose control like he had done today. He couldn't let himself get lost in thoughts of Deku and lose sleep and studying time over him.

He had always known their dynamics would change once Deku woke up. He had always known that the close proximity he had developed with soul-Deku wouldn't really last with tangible, real Deku. He had always known that not being able to feel what Deku felt first-hand and not being intrinsically connected with him would create an uncrossable bridge between them again. He had always known their relationship was bound to change as soon as things went back to normal.

But that didn't stop him from trying his best to shove Deku's soul back into his body. That didn't stop him from enduring a whole month of comatose Deku, and another one of hospitalized Deku. That wouldn't – shouldn't – stop him from enduring amnesiac Deku, too. No matter how fucking pathetic and annoyed that made him feel.

He sighed, thinking back on All Might's words. There was nothing stopping him from trying to be friends with Deku before he remembered everything. That would probably even make the boy happier once he remembered – knowing Katsuki had put an actual effort into making things more civil between them. But deep, deep down, in that part of him that was still petty, and insecure, and childish, he couldn't bring himself to try or make an effort. He couldn't bring himself to be that vulnerable – to submit himself to Deku's willingness to be friends.

His emotional outburst in Doctor Matsuo's office had done something to him. Suddenly, he felt electric and exhausted at the same time. His limbs were heavy, but his mind and heart were racing. And suddenly, the usually comforting darkness and silence of his room became too overwhelming.

He thought about calling Kirishima down to train, but in the state he was in, he would probably end up taking his anger out on his friend, and the boy had made it pretty clear he didn't want to be Katsuki's punching bag anymore. He had already trained with Icy Hot on that day, and he didn't want to raise unsolicited questions by calling him down again. All Might wasn't an option, either – the man was very strict about working-out routines, and didn't really fancy Katsuki overworking himself.

He got to his feet, skin tingling and making him feel uncomfortable. He ended up pacing his room a few times, before deciding to do some pushups and stretches just to relieve some of the tension he was feeling. By the time he was panting and sweating on the floor, he realized that uncomfortable feeling was still inside him – some sort of anxious anticipation that was screaming in his head for him to just *do something*.

He sighed. Without putting much thought into it, he got to his feet, put some slippers on, and walked out of his bedroom.

He lingered in front of Deku's room for what felt like an eternity, deciding whether he should knock or just leave. The boy was clearly doing well without him – he had friends, now, he didn't need Katsuki to babysit him or to keep him company. But still, there was something inside him – some sort of instinct, some sort of *longing* (an effect of the quirk, of course) that just made him want to check on the nerd for himself, that made him want to see him with his own eyes.

He didn't want to make himself look like a fool. Deku didn't need him, that much was obvious. But Katsuki wasn't stupid – he knew better than to convince himself that the nerd didn't *want* to see him.

Deku had spent their whole lives worshipping Katsuki – now he knew that. He knew Deku didn't look down on him.

He knew exactly how Deku felt when he looked at him – happy.

~~(He just didn't know how he felt when he looked at Deku)~~

He pounded his fist on the door abruptly, with way more force than necessary. If Deku offered any sort of response, Katsuki didn't hear him (and who could blame him?), but in less than a minute the door of the bedroom was opening, and Deku was standing in front of him, smaller than he should have been, but less shaky than Katsuki had last seen him. He was still looking skinny, though; *way* too skinny.

"K-Kacchan!", Deku exclaimed, surprised that Katsuki had shown up at his doorstep. His green eyes were wide, and Katsuki made a point of not staring into them for too long.

"At least you're wearing socks this time", Katsuki commented, arms crossed above his chest, nodding at Deku's feet.

"A-Ah, yes, I heard your advice", Deku scratched the back of his neck, and Katsuki hated that he wasn't stuttering so hard anymore. Not because of the lack of a stutter per say, but because of the fact that Deku had apparently improved over the course of the past week and he was only now noticing it. "The last thing I n-need right now is a cold", he shrugged.

"Finally got some sense into your brain, then", he scoffed. "Did All Might catch you being an idiot or did you come to that realization by yourself?"

Deku offered him a tiny chuckle, lowering his head and hiding a shy smile.

“Like I said, I listened to your advice”, he admitted, and he had his eyes fixed on Katsuki, as if searching for something.

Katsuki stared at him, not focusing on his eyes, and silence ensued for a while.

“H-How was the exam?”, Deku asked, clearly meaning to diffuse the tension.

“Child’s play”, Katsuki shrugged. “I was one of the first ones to finish it”.

“Oh”, Deku blinked. “Well. I wouldn’t expect less of you”.

“Yeah”, Katsuki said.

Silence fell again. Katsuki suddenly hated that situation, hated how awkward things felt whenever he was around Deku now. Hated not being able to talk with him anymore, not because Deku could barely speak and he could barely listen, but because they didn’t seem to be able to connect with each other anymore.

And maybe that was it. Maybe they *weren’t* supposed to connect, or be friends, or to keep that bond that had been imposed onto them going. Maybe they had just happened to be connected with a quirk, and maybe they weren’t supposed to reestablish that connection now that it had been broken. Maybe they were supposed to just go back to being rivals and move on with their lives.

Deku had his friends, Katsuki had his own. They didn’t need each other anymore. He suddenly didn’t even know why he was bothering – they clearly had nothing in common, and the fact that Deku had almost died for him didn’t mean they needed to be best friends. Katsuki didn’t even know why he didn’t just downright tell Deku, now and then, that he had One For All, and riddened himself of that burden.

He met Deku’s eyes and saw the expectation in them, and Katsuki found that he had his answer.

“Good talk”, he said dryly, at the same time Deku burst:

“Do you want to come in?”

They stared at each other for a while, awkward and stupid and painfully oblivious. The fact that they were no longer synced finally dawned once and for all upon Katsuki, and he scoffed, shaking his head.

He couldn’t make friends with Deku again. They had had a whole fucking childhood together to do that, and didn’t. Now it was a little too late. A once in a lifetime opportunity.

“Nah. You should get your shitbrain some rest, and I got stuff to do”.

“O-Okay”, Deku agreed, and whether or not he wanted to say something else, Katsuki didn’t know – he was already walking away, back turned to him.

He was nearly by the stairs when Deku blurted:

“T-Thanks for coming to see me, Kacchan”.

He didn’t dignify the boy with a response. It was clear they were on different pages – more than that, it was clear they were speaking *different languages*, even.

He slammed the door of his bedroom shut with violence, an uncomfortable feeling settling on the pit of his stomach as he finally convinced himself that all he could do was wait until Deku learned how to speak his tongue.

From: Ears

I made you another angsty playlist to help with your moping

From: Bakugou

Who the fuck says I’m moping

From: Ears

I had a feeling you could use it

Katsuki opened the link Jirou sent him and grabbed his earphone from his studying desk, placing one earbud into his good ear. He vaguely remembered the girl’s advice not to overuse his still-functional ear too much, and the thought of losing what remained of his hearing or having to wear an aid on both of them sent a jolt of anxiety across his stomach. But he still pressed play on the playlist while setting the volume on one of the lowest settings, just in case. He could use some distraction.

He was once again astonished by Ears’ talents to figure out exactly what kind of song he was in the mood for hearing, from the lyrics down to the rhythm. He vaguely wondered if she had eavesdropped on his conversation with Deku and learned he was moping because of that, and a sense of anger and indignation overwhelmed him.

From: Bakugou

Fucking eavesdropping much???

From: Ears

I literally don’t have a clue what you mean

From: Bakugou

Har har. Learn how to mind your own business

From: Ears

You’re welcome for the playlist, asshat.

From: Ears

Also just in case your paranoid brain is overthinking this, I didn’t eavesdrop on anyone. Not only that would be a misuse of my quirk, and I don’t want to get in trouble over you again, but I also don’t care enough about your confusing love life to feel bothered to eavesdrop on it

From: Bakugou

Love life????

From: Bakugou

Who the hell said I have a love life?????

From: Ears

All right Bakugou

From: Bakugou

I don’t have a fucking love life and I don’t know what the fuck you’re talking about

From: Bakugou

Are you high?

From: Ears

My bad, then.

From: Bakugou

Drugs aren’t allowed on campus, meth head

From: Ears

Sure

From: Bakugou

You suck

From: Ears

I probably learned from the best, then

From: Bakugou

Fuck you

From: Ears

Again, you're welcome

From: Ears

Idiot

From: Bakugou

You've grown some balls huh

From: Bakugou

Wouldn't have talked to me like that back when we first started UA

From: Ears

It's bc I now know you're nowhere near as intimidating as you make yourself to be

From: Bakugou

I'll fucking kill you

From: Ears

Sure you are, pup

From: Bakugou

The fuck do you mean?????

From: Ears

All bark and no bite

From: Bakugou

I'll show you the fucking bite, asshole

From: Ears

Sure

From: Bakugou

Now I see why you have lunch by yourself all the time. You're fucking irritating

From: Ears

So you REALLY didn't notice I was talking to Momo

From: Ears

I was kind of wondering if you keep doing this on purpose but turns out you're really THAT oblivious

From: Ears

Which shouldn't be this surprising, considering your current situation

From: Bakugou

What in the goddamn hell are you talking about?

From: Ears

Nothing

From: Ears

I'm off to bed. Enjoy your playlist, Blasty

From: Blasty

Go to hell

From: Blasty

What do you mean my current situation?

Read at 20:29

From: Blasty

Oi, asshole

From: Blasty

Don't fucking ignore me

Read at 20:34

From: Blasty

Fuck you

Read at 20:36

The day Deku was allowed back to classes, Katsuki woke up feeling abnormally apathetic.

Somewhere deep inside him, he knew he should at least be feeling something – this was proof Deku's recovery was working well, this was a reminder that he would be able to take his quirk back sooner than later. Of course, he still had a long path ahead of him, and he still looked skinny and bony and *weak*, but if he was attending classes again, he was getting better. This was something good, this was something worthy of celebration. Of course, Deku still wasn't allowed back at training and combat classes, just the old, regular in-class lectures, but that was still one step ahead.

But as Katsuki stepped out of his room on that morning, backpack thrown carelessly over his shoulder, he didn't feel particularly happy, joyful, or in the mood for celebrating. All he felt was a deep sense of annoyance and a hint of anxiety, since he had *no clue* what his day was about to be like.

First, he got used to having Deku around 24/7. Then, he got used to not having Deku around at *all* during his coma and his fucking time in the hospital. And even though he had spent his entire life attending to the same school as the asshole, Katsuki could no longer remember what it was like to have Deku around for a regular amount of time.

That was just who he was, wasn't it? An all-or-nothing sort of guy. Either the best of the best, or he'd rather be nothing at all. He didn't work well with mediums. He never had.

And right now, Deku was his medium. He was back into Katsuki's life, but he didn't remember what they had gone through. He had become Katsuki's friend, but he didn't know about it yet. He was faring better and back on his feet, but he wasn't well enough to take One For All and his memories back. He was no longer his rival, but he wasn't something other than that, either.

Huh. Maybe that was what was driving him crazy. He knew what life was like with Deku being so present it became annoying. He knew what life was like with Deku not being around at all. Now he was being forced to learn what life was like with Deku being around only *sometimes*.

(Before UA didn't count, because Katsuki had never thought so much about Deku at that time, so he wouldn't *know*.)

He wished there was a medium better than that. More so: he wished he wasn't so fucking *obsessed* with extremes. Why couldn't he settle for a middle-ground for once in his life? Deku was there, right? He was alive and getting better and, more importantly, back into his shitty body. That was what Katsuki had wanted from the beginning, wasn't it? To get Deku back into his body and break the soulbond and go on with his life?

So why wasn't he *happy*?

And then it dawned on him, for the first time ever since he woke up in the hospital with one deaf ear and his mother screaming at him.

He wasn't happy.

God, what a fucking mess of a situation.

He was the first one to arrive in the classroom, as usual, and he allowed his backpack to fall to the floor as he dropped heavily on his seat. The most prominent emotion he was feeling was anger, of course, but there was also a mixture of things at the bottom of his stomach that made him grit his teeth and angrily tap his foot on the floor.

Deku was about to burst through that door at any moment now, with his sparkling eyes and his wide, warm smile and his stupid freckles and his mess of a hair. And Katsuki – Katsuki would be able to do *nothing* other than just watch from afar, because there was a gap between them. A void, a blank space, and unreachable distance that he would only be able to cross once Deku got fucking better and got his cursed quirk and his memories back and *understood*. Because this was something Deku needed to *understand,* not be told. He needed to experience his memories first hand. He needed to *know*.

Katsuki decided he was better off pretending he was busy with something, lest he was forced to talk to Deku or to Shitty Hair once they arrived. So, he opened his backpack and grabbed his notebook, picking up a pen and scribbling idly at a blank page. Doctor Matsuo had once suggested it would be nice to try and make a list of things he was feeling other than anger, since it would make it easier (overtime) to identify his emotions and deal with them accordingly. So Katsuki put on his mean face, concentrated, and tried to figure out what the hell was going on in his chest.

Anger

Annoyance

Irritation

Frustration

Anxiety

Unquietness

Tiredness

Urgency

Rage

Lo –

The door to the classroom burst open abruptly and the entirety of 1-A walked in together, Deku being surrounded by their friends and smiling widely. It looked like they were coming from a reunion of sorts, as if they had all decided to celebrate Deku's return. Deku didn't even look at him as he and his friends walked into the empty classroom, all chatting and laughing and being way too fucking loud for Katsuki's liking. And as Shitty Hair found Katsuki's eyes and sent an almost apologetic shrug towards him, Katsuki found that he didn't give a shit he hadn't been invited to Deku's little welcome back party.

He wouldn't have attended anyway. What bothered him about this shit was how happy Deku seemed to be, how completely at ease and content he was standing, chatting and blabbering and *smiling*, surrounded by friends, surrounded by the people who loved him, overflowing with company and care and attention. What *bothered* Katsuki was how absolutely ok Deku was, whereas *he* was the one who had to deal with the aftermath of everything that had happened between them, whereas *he* was the one who couldn't sleep at night without living through Deku's death all over again, whereas *he* was the one who was miserable and angry and alienated from everyone who cared about him. Because the only one who could understand what he had gone through, the only person who could *really* understand, was Deku, and Deku didn't need him.

That was what bothered him the most, probably: Deku *didn't need him*. Not anymore. Somehow, for whatever fucked up ironic reason, the universe had decided it would be funny to make Katsuki need Deku for a change, and not the other way around. And it was driving him fucking crazy.

He gripped his pen and finished writing the final word of his list of emotions.

Longing

Ears appeared beside him, giving him an arrogant look that could have been almost sympathetic. Katsuki idly closed his notebook, with enough ease to not make it seem like he was trying to hide something from her.

"What do you want?", he asked, because really, he wasn't in the mood for being polite.

Jirou raised a single eyebrow at him, but didn't seem surprised.

"Charming. Good morning to you, too", she commented.

"I thought we were past that", he sighed, leaning back against his seat with one arm thrown over the backrest in a comfortable stance. Jirou shrugged.

“Yeah. I guess I can say we are”, she agreed, before crossing her arms above her chest with an almost concerned look on her usual deadpan face. “How are you doing?”

Katsuki squinted, scoffing at her.

“What the fuck is it to you?”, he asked, as if he had never heard a more ridiculous question in his life. Jirou rolled her eyes.

“You know what, I don’t know why I even bother. Listen”, she started. “I was talking to Tokoyami about music and we thought about trying some experimental stuff this week. You know, like the presentation we did at the School Festival, but just for the kicks of it. You in?”

Katsuki narrowed his eyes.

“You’re starting a *band*?”, he asked, in the most asshole-ish tone he could muster. Jirou blushed a bit, but seemed annoyed.

“We already *have* a band, and you were a part of it too, if I remember correctly”, she told him. “This is just a way to hang out and have some fun. To relax about school”.

“Tch. The fuck do *you* have to relax about?”

Jirou sighed, allowing her shoulders to slump in defeat and averting her eyes upwards as if making a silent plea for patience.

“Ok, correction: this is a way for *you* to relax about school”.

Katsuki stared at her, eyes becoming impassive. Suddenly, he didn’t feel like teasing her anymore. The joke was over.

“I don’t know what you’re talking about”.

Jirou tilted her head to the side.

“Look, Bakugou, I’m not going to question you or to make you talk about your feelings or to pat you on the head and give you hot cocoa. If you want, we can all pretend there’s nothing going on and that everything is perfectly fine in your life right now. But the fact is that everyone knows there’s a lot going on, no one judges you for it, and even though anger therapy seems to be miraculously working, despite all our initial disbelief and you still acting like an asshole, you’re also about to snap your pen in half. You obviously need to relax and distract yourself for a bit, so stop being a jerk and just come over to band practice, ok? It’s gonna be in my room, after the afternoon classes”.

Without waiting for his response, Jirou walked away and made her way over to her seat. Katsuki stared down at his own hand and found that the pen he had been holding was dangerously close to bending, the edges scorched. He dropped it to the desk and sighed heavily, cursing himself for his lack of self-control, just at the same time –

“Kacchan!”

Ah, fucking great.

He looked up to find Deku standing right beside him, backpack still carefully placed on both his shoulders and a wide, excited smile making a set of dimples appear on each of his cheeks. Katsuki's heart fluttered at the sight, but he didn't know if what caused it was a bad or a good feeling.

"What?", he asked Deku, face angry and serious. His hostile tone did nothing to affect Deku's happy smile, and the boy walked over to take his seat right behind Katsuki, since it was his assigned spot.

A seat that had been empty for months. A seat that was a perfect representation of the gap Katsuki felt between himself and the rest of the world.

Now occupied.

"I'm back!", Deku exclaimed, answering Katsuki's question. Katsuki rolled his eyes despite himself.

"I could tell that", he grumbled, grumpy. Even though his friends continued to talk in the background, Katsuki could feel it in his gut that the fuckers' attentions were glued on him and his current conversation with Deku.

Deku didn't say anything in response, which resulted on Katsuki turning around on his seat so that he could face him, a grumpy look on his face. Deku's smile still lingered on his face, but it was softer, now, almost melancholic.

"Shouldn't you be in bed resting your shitty bony body?", he asked, a bit too aggressive. This earned an amused chuckle from the nerd.

"I was cleared out to attend lectures. You know that, Kacchan".

"Yeah, but I didn't know it was today", he scoffed.

"Oh. Sorry, I thought you knew", Izuku frowned at him, sounding genuinely surprised.

"You didn't tell me", Katsuki pointed out, sounding almost resentful when he actually felt annoyed.

Izuku smiled again, lowering his head and averting his eyes.

"Well… I don't think it would have made a difference in the end", he said.

Katsuki stared at him. What the fuck?

Sensing that he was being watched, Izuku looked up at him, meeting his angry eyes. His green own widened and he quickly waved a trembling hand to indicate he meant no harm.

"No, I mean, I –", he hesitated, nervous. "I just mean that you wouldn't have wanted to come to the welcoming party anyway, that's why I didn't tell you. I didn't want you to feel like you

were forced to go".

Katsuki scoffed again, giving Izuku an almost disgusted look.

"As if you could ever force me to do anything, asshole", he scorned, before turning around to seat properly on his chair and turning his back on the nerd.

A few silent seconds went by, Katsuki glaring off at the distance.

"S-Sorry, Kacchan", Izuku ended up saying after a few moments, sounding sincere and regretful, leaning forwards on his desk so that he could speak closely to Katsuki's good ear. The proximity made his breath on Katsuki's neck send a shiver down the explosive boy's spine.

"What for, dumbass?", Katsuki asked in a low voice, not turning back to face Izuku. His arms were crossed above his chest and he was leaning back against his chair's rest, so that Izuku could talk to him more easily. To anyone watching, it just seemed that Katsuki was relaxed on his seat.

"For not telling you. Thinking back to it, I should have, I just –", he hesitated, trailing off. Katsuki scoffed and tilted his head slightly, so that he could see Izuku through his peripheral vision.

"You just *what*?", he urged, annoyed.

Izuku bit his lower lip and looked away for a moment before responding.

"I didn't think you would care?"

Katsuki scoffed. His heart felt ablaze.

We've known each other since we were four, but god forbid people assume you care about me!

"And I fucking don't", he responded, hostile. "I wasn't complaining, idiot, I was just making an observation. I don't give a rat's ass about your stupid welcome back party, just make sure you don't trip over a pebble and break your spine while you're here", he spat, turning his head and facing forwards.

He felt rather than heard Izuku move away from him as the boy leaned back on his own chair rest, and he didn't say anything else. *Good,* Katsuki thought, even though he still felt like picking his almost-broken pen and shoving it in the nerd's eye. *Idiot. I don't fucking need you, either.*

Just as Aizawa sensei walked into the classroom in his perfect timing, without one single minute of delay, Katsuki snapped his head to the side so that he could give Deku one final warning before the lecture started.

"I've grown used to *not* having you mumbling shit about the class behind me", he whispered. "So you'd better keep things that way".

Izuku didn’t have the chance to offer him a response as Aizawa sensei greeted the class and welcomed him back.

“Ok, one, two, three, go!”

“I'm in conniptions for the final act you came here for, the one derivative you manage is the one I abhor, I need a minute to elaborate for everyone the everyday bullshit things that you have done! Your impossible ego fuck is like a megalomaniacal tab on my tongue! You fuckin' touch me I will rip you apart –“

“*Fuck*!”, Katsuki shouted. The entire band stopped playing and turned to look at him.

“*What*?!”, Jirou asked, exasperated. This was the fourth time Katsuki had interrupted them, and this time, he had thrown his drumsticks on the floor in anger.

“I can’t get the fucking rhythm right!”, he retorted, clearly annoyed. She could see the way there was smoke already erupting from his hands, which were covering his eyes in a frustrated stance. Sighing, she set her microphone down and approached him.

“Bakugou…”

“I think you were doing amazing, man!”, Kirishima, who had showed up to watch their practice, encouraged from where he was sitting cross-legged on Jirou’s bed. “I don’t know what you’re talking about. You didn’t go off rhythm –“

“Yes, Bakugou”, Tokoyami nodded, impassive. “If you had gone off –“

“Stop fucking sugarcoating me, Bird Brain!”, Katsuki exclaimed, standing up, kicking his snare drum and tearing his ear protection off. He threw it on the floor with rage before walking up to Jirou. “I can’t wear the aid with that shit on, which means I can’t fucking hear properly, which means I can’t get on the fucking tempo!”

“Bakugou –“

“Shut up!”, he cut her off, and the sudden explosion of his booming voice made her flinch in surprise. Despite his hostility, the way he was screaming didn’t feel like his regular angry outbursts – there was something more broken and frustrated behind all the rage. “Just admit that bringing this band back together was a shitty idea. Or better – find another fucking drummer. One that isn’t half-deaf, while you’re at it”, he said sharply, already turning on his heels to make his way out of the room.

Jirou reached out and grabbed his wrist before he could leave, holding him in place with firm fingers when he tried to shrug away from the touch. As he turned around to give her an angry glare, Jirou glared back, impassive.

“We’re not here to make a presentation”, Jirou told him, serious. “We’re here to have fun”.

“Yeah. You can chill, bro”, Kirishima nodded, watching the scene with attention. His voice had a light tone to it, but his posture was tense, one of his legs thrown off the edge of Jirou’s bed, showing he was ready to stand up and follow Katsuki should he attempt to escape again.

“Well, do I look like I’m having the fucking time of my life?”, Katsuki snapped his head towards his friend, successfully yanking his wrist away from Jirou’s tight hold.

“That’s because you’re not *relaxing*”, Jirou pointed out, pissed off. “You want to make it perfect, and it doesn’t have to be”.

“What’s the damn point in doing shit like this if you’re not gonna make it properly?”, Katsuki scoffed. “I’m not about to half-ass –“

“It’s not about half-assing”, Jirou interrupted him. “It’s about forgetting about stuff for a while”.

“And chilling”, Kirishima provided.

Katsuki stared at him, then at Jirou. Then, he turned to look at Tokoyami, who was watching them with patience and interest, but not saying anything.

He knew he should appreciate their effort to help him relax and just forget about some of his stress, but this was only making him feel even *more* stressed out, if he had to be honest. Not being able to wear his aid and the protection at the same time was a fucking bummer, but not being able to properly hear what he was playing was driving him crazy. For the first time ever since Recovery Girl told him the bad news, he wished with all his heart that he hadn’t used his Howitzer move on a closed environment with reverberation.

He had thought he could deal with wearing a hearing aid for the rest of his life, he had thought it wouldn’t be a big deal. And it hadn’t been, so far – sure, the aid was uncomfortable, especially the one he used to wear before Pink Hair’s, but he could still hear out of one ear, so he should be fucking counting his blessings. Except now, he felt like he was being held back by his disability – and what upset him the most is that he was only now realizing it. It was only *now* dawning on him, after fucking *months*, that he had an actual disability and that he might not be able to do some of the stuff he used to do anymore.

Was this his usual response time? *Months?* Had he just spent *months* in denial?

“Bakugou”, Jirou called him, unaware of his inner epiphany. “This is the first time you play after you lost your hearing. It’s only natural you won’t get back to how you used to do it right away”.

“Yes”, Tokoyami nodded his agreement. “You can keep practicing until you get used to playing again. Musical excellence only comes from constant training”.

“And even if you never play the drums right again”, Jirou concluded. “You can try other things”.

“I don’t want to fucking try other things”, he growled, irritated and feral and frustrated. He felt defensive all of a sudden – these fuckers thought he couldn’t do it?

“I know”, she sighed. “I’m not telling you to. I’m just saying you still have other options ok?”

He sighed. He thought about trying to play without the ear protection and with his hearing aid on, but he knew that was a stupid idea – drums weren’t the most recommended instrument for people who were in risk of losing their hearing, and he wasn’t about to sacrifice his one good ear over it. He would have to get used to playing with only one ear, and that was it.

Katsuki felt a bit stupid for his angry outburst, now that he thought rationally about it. So what if he sucked at the drums now? All he had to do was get good at it again. He could do it. He wouldn’t let something as stupid as one single ear stop him. Mentally, he counted back from ten just like Doctor Matsuo had taught him and, unceremoniously picked up his drumsticks from the floor. As Kirishima and Jirou started to clap and cheer, he bent over and lifted the snare drum he had kicked to the floor, checking it for possible damage before putting it back to place.

“Yeah, you go, Bakubro!”, Kirishima celebrated.

“Right, Bakugou!”, Jirou encouraged. Tokoyami stayed silent, but nodded approvingly.

“Fine”, he said, grumpy, sitting back behind Jirou’s drum set. “Let’s get fucking back to it”.

“You wanna stay on *My Plague* or you wanna try something else?”, Jirou asked him, picking her microphone back up. Katsuki narrowed his eyes at her.

“You trying to make it easy on me, Ears?”, he asked. Jirou sighed.

“Oh boy”, Kirishima commented, shaking his head slightly.

“I was just asking you a question, Blast Boy”, she told him with a tired expression.

“Then let’s go fucking apeshit, you coward”, Katsuki gripped his drumsticks tightly. “No way I’ll get back to the top if I don’t push myself!”

Before any of them could protest, Katsuki started playing the beginning of *Moby Dick*, an intense look of aggressive determination on his angry face, and he was getting it right so far, better than he had fared with the previous song, until Kaminari, who was also a part of the band, opened the door to Jirou’s bedroom, late for their practice, and the distraction made Katsuki mess up the tempo.

“Hey, guys, sorry I’m –“

“FUCK!!!”, Katsuki screamed just as he screwed the timing up, immediately throwing one of his drumsticks at Kaminari’s head across the room. The drumstick hit the boy square on the forehead and he yelped in surprise.

“Ouch! What was that for?!”, he complained, rubbing at the sore spot between his eyes.

“You’re late, idiot”, Jirou told Kaminari with a sympathetic, albeit reprehending look. She picked up Katsuki’s fallen drumstick and turned to offer him another tired look. The boy was red on the face and staring at Kaminari with murder in his eyes. “Hey, Blasty. You wanna come up here and scream some angry lyrics to release all that tension?”

Katsuki snarled at what he interpreted as condescendence in her tone, but as Jirou raised one eyebrow at him and offered him his drumstick from the distance, he stood up and made his way to her, completely ignoring Kaminari, who was still rubbing at his sore forehead. Katsuki yanked the drumstick off Jirou’s hand, glaring at her, right before he yanked the microphone from her other hand without breaking eye contact.

“Fine”, he muttered grumpily.

“Atta boy”.

“*Fuck* you”.

“That’s the spirit”, she smiled, taking his place on the drum set. “Watcha wanna scream about?”

“Give me your best, Ears”, he said, turning his back to her. Jirou settled herself and started to play *My Plague* again – why the fuck was the girl so obsessed with this song anyway? –, but Katsuki wasn’t about to complain: he sure as fuck would love to scream those lyrics with all the might of his already sore throat.

Kaminari was struggling to pick up his equipment and get on with Tokoyami as Katsuki started to sing, while Kirishima nodded and banged his head to the rhythm (even though this wasn’t his preferred music genre).

“I haven't seen a lotta reasons to stop it, I can't just drop it, I'm just a bastard, but at least I admit it, at least I admit it! I know why you – *get with the fucking rhythm, Pikachu*! – I know why you blame yourself!”

“I’m trying, I’m trying!”, Kaminari shouted over his singing, tuning his guitar and desperately trying to fit into the song. By the time he got to it, they were almost done. Once they were finished, Kaminari was sweating and shaking all over from the pressure, to which Tokoyami patted his shoulder reassuringly a couple times.

Katsuki turned to Jirou with her microphone still in hands, a shit-eating grin on his face as he watched her put her drumsticks down.

“Well, at least now we know not even *you* can play as well as the guy with just one functional ear”, he teased, earning a laugh from Kaminari and a distraught hiss from Kirishima. Jirou

stood up, unaffected, walking over to him and taking her microphone back from Katsuki's hand.

"Nice try, but everyone knows I'm a bassist", she commented.

"*And* a singer!", Kirishima added.

"A damn good one!", Kaminari stepped in.

"Thank you", Jirou said, bowing a reverence that was purposefully exaggerated. "I guess you guys are the only ones with good taste around here", she teasingly told Katsuki before walking past him.

"Well, I can't say this shit wasn't cathartic", he admitted, picking the drumsticks back and walking towards the drum set. "But I'd rather stay on the drums, while you stay on the lyrics".

"Why? This didn't have enough screaming for you?", she raised her eyebrows.

"I can still sing while I play the drums", he said, sitting down. "But I can't move as much while I sing, and I don't like standing still like an idiot".

"Well, you could always dance while you sing", Kirishima shrugged, shaking his shoulders and arms around as if to mimic a little dance.

"And you could shut the fuck up. As if I would ever *dance*", he scorned.

"Come on, Bakubro!", Kaminari protested, grabbing Jirou by the waist and rotating her in a poor imitation of a waltz. "What's wrong with a little dancing?"

"If you don't let go of me, I'll zap you", Jirou told Kaminari in a deadpan, her arms flopping at her sides as the boy shook her and tried to urge her into dancing.

"All you gotta do is grab yourself a cute girl who wants to dance with you and hold her like this –", he threw himself on Jirou and held her right above the floor in a way that was supposed to be dance-like, and then the girl brought both her jacks up and shoved them in Kaminari's sides, zapping him. The boy yelped in surprise and let go of her, making her fall on her butt to the floor.

"A cute girl who *wants to dance with you*", she pointed out, getting back to her feet with a helping hand from Tokoyami. "Don't just go around grabbing people, dumbass".

"There, there", Kirishima comforted his friend, passing a friendly arm around his shoulder as he sat miserably on the edge of Jirou's bed, still stunned.

Katsuki was surprised to find himself smiling subtly at the scene, Jirou angrily scolding at Kaminari, Kaminari trying to defend himself and saying he was just making a demonstration, Kirishima trying to place himself between them to stop the fight, Jirou zapping both of them, Tokoyami sighing and going back to practicing his guitar on his own at the darkest corner of the room… And as Katsuki sat before the drum set, drumsticks still in hand, he realized he

was feeling just the slightest bit better about himself, despite the two angry outbursts he just had.

He felt less lonely.

From: Kacchan

So you weren't stuttering today, huh

From: Deku

Ahh! You noticed? ^-^

From: Deku

I've been working really hard on the speech therapy. I still stutter sometimes, but only when I'm nervous or uncomfortable… Otherwise, I'm basically back at speaking normally ^-^

From: Kacchan

You mean the Deku definition of normally

From: Deku

I'm not sure what that means, but probably!

From: Kacchan

I mean muttering and babbling and ranting as you always do

From: Kacchan

By the way, don't think I didn't hear you mumbling all over yourself during class earlier. Told you to cut that shit out

From: Deku

I did?

From: Deku

Wow, sorry. I didn't even realize I was doing that

From: Kacchan

Yeah, I know. That's why I didn't beat your ass right then and there

From: Kacchan

Amazing how you do that shit without noticing, smh

From: Deku

Well… tell me next time I do it so I can know

From: Kacchan

Don't tell me what to do

From: Kacchan

But fine

From: Deku

How was band practice today?

From: Kacchan

And how in the goddamn fuck do you know about that

From: Deku

Well…? Tokoyami-kun commented about it during lunch today. He said you guys were training after the afternoon classes

From: Kacchan

Gossip

From: Deku

That's hardly gossip, Kacchan.

From: Deku

But how was it?

From: Kacchan

Ok

From: Deku

I'm glad to hear it ^-^

From: Deku

Ah

From: Deku

Todoroki-kun told me you and he are training together now

From: Deku

Would you mind if I stopped by to watch next time?

From: Kacchan

Why, so you can take notes of all my moves on your shitty notebook and try to use them against me next time we fight?

From: Deku

Uh… No

From: Deku

Do you think we will have a next fight?

From: Kacchan

Well, I don't know the reason for it, but knowing the both of us I'd say that's kind of bound to happen

Deku is typing…

Deku is typing…

Deku is typing…

From: Deku

Why?

From: Kacchan

No reason, Deku. Can we go back to talking about meaningless shit?

From: Kacchan

How was your day?

From: Deku

Wow. Thanks, Kacchan

From: Kacchan

You're welcome

From: Deku

My day was fine. Going back to class was a bit tiring, if I'm being honest

From: Kacchan

Tbh I don't really get the logic behind that. The semester is almost fucking over

From: Deku

Well… I need to take the finals or else I'll have to take this semester again and fall behind

From: Kacchan

As if All Might would ever let that happen

From: Deku

All Might can't keep protecting me from everything

From: Deku

It's not right, plus I need to learn how to take my own steps

From: Deku

And I want to take the exams. That's why I have been studying so much

From: Deku

And it's a good thing they're letting me back for the final weeks, this way I can dedicate myself more

From: Kacchan

Yeah, and overwork yourself back into a hospital while you're at it, since you're a dumbfuck

From: Deku

I'm not overworking myself.

From: Deku

I only felt tired today because I'm not used to the routine anymore. I'm sure I'll get the hang of it soon! ^-^

From: Kacchan

Sure you will

From: Deku

You don't think I will?

From: Kacchan

????

From: Kacchan

I just told you 'sure you will"

From: Deku

Oh

From: Deku

Sorry, that came off sarcastic

From: Kacchan

Yeah, because it's a fucking text conversation so you can't see my currently honest face

From: Deku

Do you also get the feeling we've been talking to each other way more over text than we do in real life?

Katsuki stared at the screen. What the fuck?

From: Kacchan

What the hell is that supposed to mean

From: Deku

Well…

Deku is typing…

Deku is typing…

Deku is typing…

From: Deku

It's just I rarely ever see you anymore ever since I left the hospital

From: Deku

I mean, I don't mean it to sound like I'm complaining or anything. It's just… I got used to you being around, you know?

From: Deku

I thought we were kind of friends now

From: Deku

Or, well, as friendly as we can be, given our history

Katsuki scoffed.

From: Kacchan

Being friends with each other doesn't mean sharing a bed, Deku

Deku is typing…

Deku is typing…

Deku is typing…

From: Deku

Who said anything about sharing a bed?

Katsuki blushed.

From: Kacchan

You know what I fucking mean. Just because we're friends, it doesn't mean we have to see each other all the damn time

From: Kacchan

I know that's probably your concept of friendship since Round Face and Four Eyes keep breathing on your damn neck 24/7, but that's not how I do things

From: Deku

Kacchan, I'm not complaining

From: Deku

I also don't want to pressure into anything, which is why I didn't mention the welcome back party

From: Deku

I just

From: Deku

Well

From: Deku

Never mind

From: Kacchan

Well, just go ahead and spit it

From: Deku

It's nothing

From: Kacchan

Stop playing these fucking games and just say what you want to say

Deku is typing…

Deku is typing…

Deku is typing…

From: Deku

I miss you

Katsuki stared at the screen.

From: Deku

And I'm sorry if that makes you uncomfortable, I don't want to… suffocate you, or whatever

From: Deku

It's just I grew used to having you around every day while I was in the hospital, and now I barely see you anymore

From: Deku

So it's kind of inevitable I miss you, because if I see someone every single day for over a month and then when I get better I don't see that person anymore I'm bound to miss them, it's just a physical reaction, it's not something I can control

From: Kacchan

Deku. Shut up

From: Kacchan

I know what you mean, stop trying to justify yourself

From: Kacchan

It's just

From: Kacchan

This shit isn't easy for me. You know that.

From: Kacchan

Also your shitty friends are around you all the damn time nowadays, so I don't really feel like I need to keep you company anymore

Deku is typing…

Deku is typing…

From: Deku

Is that why you visited, then?

From: Kacchan

What?

From: Deku

Back when I was in the hospital. You only visited me because you thought I needed company?

From: Kacchan

Well… Yeah?

From: Kacchan

Why else would I visit during night time, when I knew no one else would be around?

From: Deku

So you didn't want to be seen there with me?

From: Kacchan

Did you eat shit?

From: Kacchan

I literally just told you I visited during night time because I knew there would be no one there at that time to keep you company

From: Kacchan

Learn how to fucking read

From: Deku

Oh right

From: Deku

Sorry

From: Kacchan

Yeah

Deku is typing…

Deku is typing…

From: Deku

But still, I kind of wish we'd see each other more often

From: Kacchan

Didn't I just visit you like two days ago and talk to you today

From: Deku

Well, yes, but your visit lasted five minutes and you didn't even go into my room

From: Deku

And I have a feeling you only talked to me today because I sit right behind you

Kacchan is typing…

Kacchan is typing…

From: Kacchan

What do you want me to do, Deku?

From: Deku

What?

From: Kacchan

Something tells me you're trying to tell me something, but I have no idea what it is so spit it

Deku is typing…

Deku is typing…

From: Deku

It's nothing

From: Deku

I just miss you, that's all

From: Kacchan

All right

Deku is typing…

Deku is typing…

From: Deku

All right

From: Deku

Uh, just one sec, mom's calling

From: Kacchan

Pick it up. I'm off to bed anyway

From: Kacchan

See you in class tomorrow

From: Deku

Ok

Katsuki set his phone aside and closed his eyes, already knowing he wouldn't be getting much sleep.

The last day of class before the Winter Break began was frantic for 1-A, but peaceful for Katsuki. That was because he knew his friends were going out to the mall after the last class in order to buy winter clothes and eat, and then they would celebrate together at the district's yearly Winter Festival. This was the reason why the day was frantic for *them*. The reason why the day was peaceful for Katsuki was because he wouldn't be attending to any of those things – which meant he would have the entire dorm just for himself.

He took a well-deserved nap after coming back from Aizawa sensei's final class and the training with All Might, grateful for the winter break and for the fact that he would finally find some time for himself. He had been coming up with some neat ideas for his hand grenades, something that would make the kick of them smoother and would absorb part of the sound of his explosions, so they didn't risk giving him feedback of fucking up the hearing of his good ear. He was looking forward to having the time to work on that, even if he *wasn't* looking forward to hearing his mom screaming at him over whatever small thing he did every single day.

He was looking forward to not being around Deku, either, but his reasons for that were completely opposite to whatever reason the Katsuki-from-the-past might have had to want to keep away from the nerd before. No, he was looking forward to not being around Deku because being back at home took some pressure away from having to interact with the shitty nerd. There, as they inhabited the same student dorm, the same school, the same cafeteria, the same campus, Katsuki felt like he was under some sort of obligation to interact with the amnesiac piece of shit. Now, going back home and taking some time to himself, Katsuki

could only hope the nerd would use his own time to find a way to get ripped during their school break and come back to school in shape.

Well, not in full shape. Katsuki knew Deku needed more time than a school break could provide in order to get 100% better, but that would still be an advancement. That would be a school-break closer to giving the nerd back One For All, his memories, and to finally have a talk about what had happened between them and solve things. Katsuki kind of couldn't wait to get that weight off his chest, since Deku was literally the only person he could talk to about that subject and Deku was literally the only person who currently didn't know one single thing about it.

He cuddled into his covers and didn't even bother to check his phone before taking his nap, knowing it would be filled with Kirishima's texts begging him to go with them to the Winter Festival at least. That was the last thing he wanted to do – not only because he hated crowds and festivals, but also because he felt bone-deep tired and he wanted to rest before he packed his shit and went home. He was pretty sure his friends had already packed their stuff, eager to leave UA for a while, and usually, Katsuki would have already packed his as well – but he was so tired, and it was so cold, and his bed was really inviting, especially after his afternoon training session with All Might. So he allowed himself to fall into a dreamless sleep – a luxury he hadn't had much access to, recently – and only woke up when it was almost 6 p.m.

After going to the bathroom and minding his own business, Katsuki decided to make a trip downstairs and grab himself something to eat. Since all of the assholes would probably head home straight from the festival, that meant he could cook whatever he wanted without having them beg for scraps or make demands. He threw a cozy hoodie on, put on some socks because it was fucking *winter*, and walked out of his room, feeling relaxed and content.

Of course, since his life was fucking cursed, that feeling didn't last for long. As soon as he stepped into the common room, he noticed the TV was on – and he could spot the mess of a green hair sticking out from the back of the couch, facing away from him.

Ah, fucking great. He couldn't get *one* break, could he?

He and Deku had barely talked to each other ever since that awkward texting conversation from two weeks before. Surely, Deku still talked to him during class or whenever the fuck he managed to catch Katsuki alone, but otherwise… No texts. No visits, either. Katsuki could sense the boy was upset, and he was too smart to pretend he didn't know the reason why.

He missed Deku, too. He fucking hated to admit it and he would never do so aloud, but he did. But telling Deku that he missed him only to carry on his journey of keeping his distance from the nerd… That would probably result on a lot of questions Katsuki wasn't ready to answer. He had already accepted that there was nothing he could do but wait until Deku got better enough to regain his memories – letting the boy fully into his life before that was equivalent to shooting himself on the foot. He had to keep his distance. All he could do was hope Deku would understand once he remembered everything.

But he was completely alone with the boy at the dorm, now. If he didn't interact with him – now *that* would raise questions he didn't want to answer.

Plus, he did miss Deku, as ridiculous as that sounded to him. Indulging in that couldn't really hurt, right?

They would be apart for what, two weeks? That was a long and a short time, simultaneously. But the fact was this was the last chance Katsuki would get of seeing the boy before the break began, and he kind of wanted to dive into the chance of not having their annoying nosy friends around to eavesdrop on them for fucking once.

"So you didn't go with them to that winter shit?"

Deku startled on the couch, jumping and snapping his head to where Katsuki was standing. He had clearly not heard or seen his approach.

The look on Deku's face as he spotted Katsuki standing there was weird, but Katsuki didn't really know how to explain why. The first thing he noticed was that the boy was wearing a Golden Era All Might hoodie, sweatpants, All Might themed socks and that he was sitting cozily beneath a cover. In his hand, there was a joystick, and only then did Katsuki realize he was playing something by himself.

The sight of Deku sitting there, alone, joystick in hand and in his All Might merch, looking so bony and even a bit sick, reminded Katsuki of their childhood, and of the years he spent mocking Deku for scenes just like that. This sent a spark of melancholy and regret down his spine, and it probably ended up showing in his face – he had never been good at hiding these sorts of things. If Deku noticed this, however, he didn't mention it, too nervous attempting to put his own thoughts into words.

"Oh – no, n-no, I didn't go with them. It's too cold, and I didn't want to risk catching something", he shrugged. And then, right afterwards, he frowned. "Didn't… Didn't you go?"

Katsuki stared at him.

"I'll give you one chance to guess the answer to that".

That earned a laugh from Izuku, who awkwardly scratched the back of his neck.

"Oh, well, I can see you *didn't* go, but –", he hesitated. "W-Why?"

Katsuki walked past the sofa and the TV, staring at Izuku.

"I don't like this kind of shit. Too many people, too many meaningless protocols. I'd rather just stay here and mind my own business".

Izuku mumbled something, but Katsuki didn't really manage to hear it from where he was standing.

"What?", he asked. Izuku blushed and looked away.

"N-Nothing".

Then he grabbed his joystick and went back to playing whatever he had been playing before.

Katsuki sighed. He was still upset, then.

Fuck it.

“You ate already?”, he asked.

“Yeah, yeah”, Deku said, focused on the game. Katsuki scoffed.

“K”.

He headed to the kitchen, finding all the tableware was dry and put away. Something told him Deku hadn’t bothered to cook, wash the dishes, dry them, and put them away, which meant he hadn’t fucking eaten. *I swear to fucking god,* Katsuki thought, grabbing the ingredients he needed to make themselves food.

(He was pretty glad to open the freezer and find pork ribs in there).

He cut the ingredients and started cooking in silence – he wouldn’t have been able to hear Deku from the common room even if he tried. Deku, on the other hand, stayed where he was, playing his stupid game and not even bothering to go to the kitchen keep Katsuki company. Not that Katsuki wanted him to, and he knew better than to expect it. He knew Deku was still upset, and he knew it was his fault. There wasn’t much he could do about that, though. He could only wait.

He kept telling himself that, he came to realize. Almost like a mantra.

Almost like brainwash.

Once everything was settled and there was nothing that Katsuki could do but wait until the food was ready, he walked back into the common room, sitting on the couch as far away from Deku as he could. Deku didn’t look at him.

“What are you playing?”

“Uh, Portal 2”.

“Tch”.

Deku kept playing in silence, and Katsuki decided to check his messages. Just as he’d imagined it, there were hundreds of texts from all sorts of friends, begging him to come along and then scolding him for not doing so. He scoffed and rolled his eyes, marking the conversations as read without responding to any of them.

“Uh, you…”, Izuku broke the silence after a few moments of awkward silence, pausing the game and turning to Katsuki. “Do you want to play with me?”

Katsuki stared at him, then at the joystick in his hand, then at Deku again. He said nothing.

“O-Ok”, Deku said, retrieving his hand and looking away from Katsuki at the boy’s silence. Katsuki sighed.

“If I do, will you stop this being-mad shit?”

Izuku frowned, meeting his eyes again.

“What?”

“You’re clearly fucking mad at me, even though *I* wasn’t the one who left you here all by yourself the moment our break began”.

Izuku squinted at him with indignation before scoffing and shaking his head, as if deciding there was no way Katsuki was being serious. He pressed play and went back to his game.

“What? It’s true”, Katsuki said, even though he *knew* it wasn’t true. He didn’t know exactly why he seemed so bound on riling Deku up out of a sudden, but he couldn’t really stop himself. He felt angry, upset, alone, and entitled to be petty.

Izuku paused the game again and turned to look at him, this time genuinely annoyed.

“Seriously, Kacchan?”

“Yeah”, he answered without missing a beat.

Izuku scoffed again, disbelief written all over his face.

“Don’t act like you even *knew* I was here”, Izuku reprimanded. “You totally found me here by accident, so don’t… D-Don’t *act* like you *chose* to stay here at the dorm with the sole purpose of keeping me company”.

Katsuki felt his face grow tenser.

“And don’t talk badly of my friends, either”, Izuku added, sounding uncharacteristically disapproving. “I was the one who insisted they should go, instead of staying to babysit me. They deserve to have some fun; they shouldn’t have to keep from that because of me”.

Katsuki stared at him for a while, but instead of staring back, Izuku pressed play again and decided to completely ignore him, clearly pissed off.

“When did you learn how to stand up for yourself?”, Katsuki asked. Izuku glanced at him.

“Well, I had to do it at some point, didn’t I?”

All right. That settled the mood.

A grim-ass fucking mood.

And it made Katsuki pissed. It felt like they were having the same conversation for the millionth fucking time.

“I already told you I was fucking sorry for all the shit I did to you”, he complained angrily. This time, when Deku paused the game, he set his joystick down on his lap, turning fully

towards Katsuki and finally offering him his whole attention.

“You did?”

“Yeah, I did”.

“Oh, you did. You came up to me and said ‘I’m sorry for everything I ever did to you, Izuku’?”

“Tch. What, you want me to crawl at your feet and beg for your special, holy pardon? Is that what you expect?”

“Oh, I certainly don’t expect that of *you*. But you can’t come up to me, say you were and asshole to me and did things that were messed up, say you’re trying to *be better*, and then tell me you said ‘I’m sorry’”.

Katsuki stared at him.

“You didn’t say ‘I’m sorry’. You never did”.

What do you want me to fucking tell you? Hah? That I’m fucking sorry? Is that what your shitty nerd ass wants to fucking hear? Fine. I’m fucking sorry. I’m fucking sorry for all those times I was an asshole to you, I’m sorry for putting you down, I’m sorry for letting go of you. I’m sorry for fucking letting go of you, even though I promised I wouldn’t. Is that what you wanted to fucking hear? So where the fuck are you, hah? Where the fuck are you, you fucking, shitty, smug bastard?

He swallowed dry.

“And you know what?”, Izuku continued, getting even angrier at Katsuki’s silence. “For all that talk about being better, I don’t see much effort from your part”.

All right, that settled it.

“Oh, shut the fuck up”, Katsuki scoffed, annoyed. “You love making demands, don’t you? How about this: it’s not my fucking fault you’re so busy with your shitty friends all the time and don’t have the time to hang out anymore. So, if anything –“

“*Hang out*?”, Izuku interrupted him, frowning in indignation. “When did we *ever* hang out, Kacchan?”

God, this amnesia shit was going to drive Katsuki crazy, he swore it –

“That’s not the fucking point, Deku”.

“Oh, yeah? Then tell me what the point is, because I don’t know”, he shook his head. His eyes were moist with tears, which was expected – Deku cried over literally *anything*, it was virtually impossible for him not to cry during an argument (Katsuki knew that from experience). His face, however, was angry, in a way that made him ridiculously cute because he never looked really menacing while angry. It was like yelling at a rabbit. “I really don’t

know, Kacchan", Izuku continued. "You keep saying you'll tell me all about what happened when I'm ready, whenever that is, by the way, and everyone refuses to tell me as well because of *you*! So please, go ahead and tell me what's the point, because I'm not so sure anymore".

Katsuki glared at him, eyes narrowed in anger and… something else.

"You keep talking about stuff we never did and expecting me not to mention it, you keep acting as if we were friends, as if we had *always* been friends, but I'm starting to think you and I remember our childhoods very differently".

Ouch. Ok, low blow, but not exactly unfair.

"And no, I'm not trying to throw anything at your face, Kacchan", Izuku added, probably noticing Katsuki's reaction. "But I'm just really tired of this. I don't know what you want. I don't know what you expect of me. You don't visit me, and you say we don't see each other anymore because of my friends, but every night I sit alone in my room hoping you'll show up like you've done for a month, but you just don't, even though I'm all by myself, with no one to get in your way. And then you have the nerve to get angry at me for, for what? Hanging out with other people who *actually* want to hang out with me? People who keep me company? People who are my *friends?* Well, I'm really sorry if the fact that I no longer depend on your friendship to be happy bothers you, but I guess I just got tired of waiting for you to make a move!"

Deku's face was flushed and he was panting, angry. Katsuki felt himself starting to get worried about the boy passing out from the sheer effort he was making, because Deku's forehead was already covered in a thin layer of sweat even though it was snowing outside. What the hell.

"All my life, I hoped the day would come when we would go back to being friends", Deku continued, voice shaky. "All this time, I've been waiting for the day when we'd get past whatever happened that broke us apart. But you said you watched me die in front of you, and you said that messed you up, but apparently not even *that* was enough to make you care, was it? And I kind of wish you would just go back to hating me the way you used to do, because at least *then* I knew exactly what to expect from you!"

Ok, enough.

"Shut up", Katsuki said, angry. "Don't say that. I get that you're fucking pissed, but you don't get to say that I don't care –"

"Oh, I'm sorry, you *do*? I didn't pick that up from the way you've been *avoiding* me!"

"I was *avoiding* you because I don't fucking know what to do, ok?!", Katsuki snapped. Izuku's mouth closed, and before Katsuki knew better, he was on his feet. "You're fucking right, we weren't friends. We broke apart. And I was a dick. And since you want to hear it so fucking much, there you go: I'm sorry. I'm sorry for telling you to kill yourself, for burning your stupid notebook, and for all the fucked-up shit I did even before that. But me being

sorry doesn't change the fact that it's already happened, it's in the past, and I'm really tired of you shoving it in my face!"

Izuku stared at him, looking close to shocked.

"Even if your shitty ass brain can't pick it up, I *am* trying to be better. I'm being forced to attend these shitty therapy sessions because of *you*, and I fucking lost my hearing because of *you,* and I was ready to blow myself and everyone who was down there in that damn sewer with me up to hell if it meant I would catch the asshole who almost killed *you*. And no, I'm not trying to put the blame on you, because guess what? I would do it all over again. I've been through hell and back, I watched you fucking die because of me and I can't even sleep at night because whenever I close my eyes all I can think about is that, but I would do that shit all over again if it meant you end up safe. So you don't fucking come to my fucking face and tell me I don't fucking care about your dumb ass".

There were tears in Izuku's eyes. There were tears in Katsuki's, as well, but they were angry tears. He tried to remember every advice Doctor Matsuo ever gave him on how to calm himself down.

"I get that you're pissed", he said, because *acknowledging other people's feelings is important when you're trying to acknowledge your own*, "and I get that you're upset I've been avoiding you. You're *right* to. But don't fucking come to me and tell me I don't care about you, or that you'd rather I hate you. I might not have cared, *fuck*, I might have spent our whole shitty lives *not* caring about you and hating you, but after everything we've been through, after everything I told you, don't tell me I don't care *now*".

Izuku's hands were shaking and his lower lip was quivering.

"K-Kacchan…"

"Fuck", Katsuki interrupted him, because he smelled smoke and his fucked-up hearing had clearly not picked up the constant beeping coming from the oven. "The goddamn katsudon is burning", he announced, before rushing into the kitchen.

"K-Katsudon…?", Izuku muttered, confused.

Katsuki opened the oven and grabbed the tray with his bare hands, placing it on the kitchen table with a loud clack and checking its contents. The katsudon was burnt around the edges, but the middle was still edible. What a fucking shitshow.

Izuku appeared at the kitchen door, curious, his cover wrapped around his shoulders and torso and dragging on the floor behind him like a cape. He looked confused and curious, but his eyes widened in shock as he spotted the tray of half-burnt katsudon sitting on the kitchen table.

"Kacchan", he said, shocked, before finding Katsuki's crimson eyes. "Y-You… You made…?"

“It’s burnt”, Katsuki cut him off with angry frustration, not looking at him. He turned his back to Izuku and grabbed two bowls from the cabinet.

“W-Wait”, Izuku frowned. “Did you grab that hot tray with your bare hands?!”

“It doesn’t hurt me, asshat”, Katsuki scoffed, walking past the thin boy in order to grab the fuming tray without mittens *again*. Izuku downright yelped in shock. “My quirk is to make explosions with my *hands*, if heat hurt me, I’d be fucked”.

“Wow”, Izuku followed him out of the kitchen and watched as he set the tray and the bowls on the dining table. “I never thought of that before”.

“Course you didn’t”.

“Can I see?”

Katsuki turned his head to frown at him.

“What?”

“Your hands”, Izuku added shily, approaching him. He looked ridiculous like that, not only because both his sweatpants and his hoodie were too big for his muscle-less body, but also because of the way he had managed to tuck himself into his cover like it was a half-poncho, half-cape.

Katsuki just stood there, staring at Izuku as if he had grown a second head, whereas Izuku reached out and grabbed one of Katsuki’s hands. He turned it so that the palm was facing upwards, glistening red from the hot tray and covered in rough callouses he had grown over the years.

Izuku traced the callouses with the tips of his shaky fingers. Katsuki let him, watching with some level of embarrassment as Izuku studied his hand with interest and analytical curiosity in his lively eyes.

“Got what you wanted?”, Katsuki raised an eyebrow at him after what felt like an eternity, and Izuku let go of his hand as if he had been suddenly burned by it. Heat rose to his cheeks and he looked away, avoiding Katsuki’s eyes.

“You sure it doesn’t hurt?”

“What?”

“Grabbing hot trays like that”.

“I think I would know, wouldn’t I? Since they’re *my* hands?”

“Okay”.

“They don’t hurt, Deku”.

Izuku locked eyes with him.

“All right”.

“Grab a seat and eat some, since I know you were lying before. Take some from the middle, it didn’t burn there”, Katsuki said, grabbing his own self a seat and pointing at the un-scorched part of the katsudon. Izuku followed his lead, and they both sat down and began to serve themselves with the food.

“How did you know?”

“That you were lying?”

“That katsudon is my favorite food”.

Oh, right. Shit.

Katsuki could actually feel the blood draining from his face, but tried to keep his composure.

“Lucky guess”.

Izuku sighed, clearly disappointed.

“Fine”, Katsuki sighed, hoping to make amends. “I remember you talking about it once”.

This wasn’t necessarily a lie… but it wasn’t the truth, either. Katsuki felt bad about it.

“Oh”, Izuku blinked, seeming to believe that.

“Yeah”.

They began to eat in silence, but Katsuki watched Izuku’s face with close – yet subtle – attention as he took his first bite. The way the boy’s eyes widened and searched for Katsuki’s in appreciation sent a tiny spark of self-righteousness to Katsuki’s stomach.

“Kacchan”, Izuku said with his mouth full. “This is *sugoi*”.

“I know”, he shrugged, offering Izuku an obnoxious smirk.

“How can you cook so well?!”, Izuku exclaimed, taking another bite. “This is ridiculously good”.

“You’re welcome”.

“I feel better about not having eaten before. This was totally worth it”.

“Yeah. You wanna tell me about that?”

“Huh?”

“Why the fuck didn’t you eat and then lied to me about it?”

Izuku blushed.

“Oh, I was going to eat in a moment. I just didn’t feel like it at the time”.

“You know you gotta look after yourself if you plan on getting better, right? Even a toddler would know that”.

Izuku eyed him for a moment, looking a mixture of uncertain and affectionate.

“Yeah… I promise you I was going to eat; I wasn’t about to throw my recovery on the trash or anything. I just wasn’t feeling hungry, so I decided to wait for a while until I did”.

“Huh”, Katsuki said, deciding to let the subject drop. *No use dwelling in things that already happened.*

They ate in silence for a while, and Izuku was halfway through his bowl when he said:

“It kind of freaks me out, you know”.

Katsuki stared at him.

“What does?”

He was silent for a moment.

“When you talk to me like that”.

“Like what?”

“Like… Like you actually care”.

Katsuki sighed, but before he could say anything, Izuku added:

“And yes, I *know* you care, but it’s still… Weird”.

Katsuki chewed on his food harder.

“I’m not complaining”, Izuku clarified. “Or trying to shove what happened in your face. I’m just… I’m just saying”.

Silence for a while.

“I like it”, he concluded. Katsuki scoffed.

“Of course you do. You’re a soft piece of shit”.

Izuku rolled his eyes.

“You see, that’s *totally* the opposite of what I was talking about”.

“What?”, Katsuki shrugged. “I’ve always had a foul mouth. And if there’s one thing I’m not, it’s soft. You know that better than anyone”.

Izuku chuckled, but didn’t say anything else. Katsuki hesitated for a moment.

“But I meant what I said. I do care. Even if I’m still an asshole sometimes. I just don’t know how to show it”.

Izuku looked at him, an undecipherable look on his face.

“And the reason I’ve been avoiding you”, he shrugged, averting his eyes from Izuku. “Is because I don’t want to keep hurting you by accident”.

And that was the first completely sincere thing he had told Izuku that night. Because that was the truth, wasn’t it? That was the main reason behind his entire dilemma. He wanted to be close to Deku, but couldn’t, because Deku didn’t remember. He wanted to be friends with him, but couldn’t, because he had to keep lying to him until he recovered his memories. He wanted to go back to the relationship he used to have with soul-Deku, but couldn’t, because this Deku had no clue what they had shared and lived together and the only way for him to truly understand everything that Katsuki felt and thought and remembered was through remembering it all as well. And Katsuki *knew* he couldn’t just go back to being an asshole to the nerd.

He didn’t want to.

It was hard, having to talk to this Deku while pretending everything was ok, while having to lie all the time. Things would be so much easier if he just remembered. They would be so much better.

Katsuki felt tired. He hated lying and dishonesty. He hated that he had to do this, he hated that he had to take One For All to save Deku’s life. He hated it. It felt like he was living a secret, like he was living a lie. He just wanted a break. He just wanted this entire shit to be over.

“Kacchan”, Izuku said, voice soft and gentle. Katsuki looked at him. “I can take it”.

For some reason, that felt like a punch to the stomach.

“Not just –“, Izuku continued. “Not just you being rude and mean to me. I’ve dealt with that my whole life, and if I have to –“

“You *don’t* have to –“

“*If* I have to”, Izuku interrupted him. “I’ll keep doing it. But I know that whatever it is you’re not telling me, whatever happened after the villain attack –“, he sighed. “Whatever it is”, he repeated, eyes fixed on Katsuki, as serious as they had ever looked. “I can take it”.

Katsuki stared at him.

“You can tell me”.

He studied Izuku's face, so bony and pale and weak. He saw the anticipation in his eyes, and the trust in them. A trust Katsuki wasn't entirely sure he deserved, because well, it was his fault Deku was quirkless again. And he didn't even know it.

He deserved to know. Katsuki knew he deserved to know. Maybe Katsuki should just tell him.

What would Deku do? Hate him for all eternity? Never speak to him again? Thank him for saving his life? He honest to god didn't know.

But sitting there, looking into the deep green of Deku's eyes, seeing the trust etched in them, Katsuki knew he couldn't keep lying to him any longer. He couldn't keep delaying this, he couldn't keep telling himself he had to wait – Deku would have to know, sooner or later. Maybe telling him everything that happened would finally free him from the anxiety that kept bottling at the pit of his stomach, of the guilt that kept him awake at night, of the sorrow that seemed to accompany him wherever he went. Maybe telling Deku everything would finally set Katsuki free.

He had always been a man of action. He didn't sit around and wait. He stood up for himself and got things done. Like Doctor Matsuo had said, he needed to face his problems face-first, not run away from them. Nothing good ever came from waiting. And maybe that was the reason why he had been feeling so bad about himself, lately – he wasn't *acting* like himself. Being lenient wasn't in his blood.

He suddenly felt brave, braver than he had felt in weeks. A renewed strength made its way into his system.

"Deku, I –"

"WATASHI GA KITA! WATASHI GA KITA! WATASHI GA KITA!", All Might's booming voice echoed from the sofa.

"What the *fuck*?", Katsuki asked, snapping his head towards the sound. Izuku's eyes widened and he immediately got to his feet, mouth still full, before giving Katsuki an apologetic look and rushing back to the common room. There, he fussed with the cushions on the sofa before successfully retrieving his phone, which was ringing.

"Hi, A-All Might!", he answered the phone, voice high-pitched and nervous.

(Katsuki was frankly astonished at how Deku could still feel so nervous whenever he spoke to All Might, even after all this time. He had eaten the guy's *hair,* for fuck's sake. It couldn't get more awkward than that.)

"W-What?", Izuku asked, frowning and turning to look at the window. He walked over, pulling the curtain open just enough to take a glimpse outside. "What, really? No, no, the curtain was closed, I'm just seeing it now. Are you safe? Where are you? Oh… Ok. All right. Yes. Oh, no, I mean, no. I didn't go to the Winter Festival, I'm at the dorm. No, Kacchan is with me. Yes, he didn't go. Too many people, he doesn't like it".

There was silence for a while as Izuku listened to whatever All Might was saying.

“No, ok. No, sure, I can stay here. No, no, no, really, it’s fine, I can stay. I hadn’t even packed yet. Yes, I’ll call my mom and tell her. I’ll tell Kacchan, too. Yes, I’m sure. *Yes,* I’m feeling better. I promise. Uh huh. I did. I did, it’s already broken, I’m drinking plenty of water and now I’m having dinner. Yes, Kacchan cooked. Yes, I *am* eating, don’t worry. Well, yes, that’s why I didn’t go with them. Uh huh. Yeah. Yeah, you too! Bye”.

Izuku hung up the phone and turned on his heels to face Katsuki.

“So… I have some bad news?”, he grimaced. Katsuki stared at him with a blank face.

“Spit it”, he said simply, continuing to eat his food.

“Uh, the weather’s been acting crazy recently, right? And now there’s this snow storm going on and…”, he hesitated, sitting back by the table with Katsuki. “Well. The roads are closed off and they had to deactivate public transport. So we’re kind of stuck here”.

Katsuki stared at him.

“What the fuck?”, he settled for saying, frowning. “The fucking *roads* are closed off? What, is the world ending or some shit?”

“No, it’s just – like, really a bunch of snow”, Izuku explained, sounding as surprised as Katsuki. “It shouldn’t stay closed for too long and All Might said the police is trying to figure out if this was quirk-caused, but no one should go out for a while. So… we kind of have to stay here until they clear us out”, he shrugged apologetically.

“Great”, Katsuki growled, grabbing his phone. “Fucking *spectacular*”.

“I’m sorry”, Izuku said, giving him a sad smile. “You should probably call your mom –“

“Yeah, yeah”, Katsuki interrupted, already taking the phone to his ear. “You go ahead and call yours”, he told Izuku, just as his call patched through. “Oi, Shitty Hair. Where are you?”

“Bakugou!”, Kirishima exclaimed enthusiastically from the other end of the call. “I’m home already, bro, you wouldn’t *believe* the amount of snow –“

“Yeah, I’ve heard about it”, Katsuki cut his friend off, impatient. “Did everyone get home before this shit started?”

“Uh, yeah, yeah, everyone’s fine”, Kirishima said. “It started like, half an hour ago, so as soon as we saw it was getting bad, everyone went home. What about you, bro?”

“I’m still at the dorm”.

“What? Why?!”

“I decided to take a nap and then I made myself something to eat when I woke up. I only heard about this shit now, so I’m stuck here until it’s better”.

“Oh, shit, man, that sucks. You’ll probably have to wait until tomorrow, they aren’t really telling us much about it yet. Maybe keep an eye on the news?”

“Yeah, I’ll do that. Now that I know you assholes aren’t buried under a mountain of ice, I’ll call my old woman and tell her I’ll have to stay here. Bye”.

“All right, man, you do that – oh, wait, wait, wait!”

“What?”

“You’re at the *dorm*?”

“Uh… Yeah?”

“Is… Is Midoriya still there?”

Katsuki sighed.

“Yes, Kirishima”.

“And you two are alone?!?”

“Yes”.

“*Oh my god*”.

“What?”

“N-Nothing! Nothing, man, nothing. Just wanted to make sure you weren’t there alone”.

“I’m not. I’m also hanging up now”.

“Bakugou”.

“*What?*”

“Just…”, Kirishima hesitated. “Try not to kill each other, ok?”

“What the *fuck* does that mean?”

“What? You know how you can get! Just promise me you’ll take things easy. In *all possible senses* of the word”.

“I have no idea what you mean, but I don’t plan on murdering Deku in cold blood”, he made sure to look at the nerd, who was also on the phone but looked up at the mention of his name. “That would be stupid, since I’d be the only suspect”.

Izuku frowned, but continued to talk with his mom. Katsuki smirked.

“Aw, man. I can’t believe this is happening”.

“What?”

“*Nothing*. Just, uh, stay safe. And call me or text me if you need anything, all right, bro?”

“Fine. Don’t worry about it”.

“Ok. See ya later”.

“Bye”.

Katsuki hung up, before opening his text chat.

From: Brat

Not making it home today. Snow storm or some shit. I’m at the UA dorm, will stay here for the night.

From: Old Hag

Are you there alone?

From: Brat

What does it matter

From: Old Hag

So no?

From: Brat

Deku’s here.

From: Old Hag

All right

From: Old Hag

Let me know when you’re coming home, then

From: Old Hag

And don’t you think about stepping out of that dorm. The snow is fucking savage

From: Brat

Whatever

He put the phone down, looking at Deku.

“You spoke to your mom?”, the boy asked Katsuki.

“Yeah. You?”

“Yeah”.

Katsuki’s phone vibrated. He stared down at the screen.

From: Deku’s Mom

Hello Katsuki-kun. Are you with Izuku?

Katsuki sighed, rolling his eyes.

From: Katsuki Bakugou

Yeah, he’s with me. We’re at the dorm. Don’t worry, I’m not letting him out

From: Deku’s Mom

Thank you. Would it be too much to ask you keep an eye on him? He’s been dealing with a nasty fever ever since this morning and it was only now getting better. I was on my way to pick him up when the snow storm began. Hopefully I will make it there tomorrow, but I would hate for his state to get worse in that meantime.

Katsuki stared up at Izuku, eyes angry. Unceremoniously, he shoved his hand at Izuku’s forehead, feeling how warm it felt. Izuku immediately blushed.

“You have a fucking *fever*?”, he asked, full of indignation, remembering what shitshow it had been last time Deku’s brains boiled from fever. Izuku shook his head.

“It broke! It broke, it’s better”, he said. He wasn’t lying – his skin felt clammy and warm, but not extremely so. If he did still have a fever, it was a really low one.

“Is that why you didn’t fucking eat?”, Katsuki confronted him, angry. Izuku sighed, allowing his shoulders to slump in frustration, but shaking his head.

“Kacchan, you don’t have to worry. Ok? I’m taking my medicine, I just ate, I’m better”, he pointed at his empty bowl of katsudon.

Katsuki stared at him. Maybe he was overreacting. Deku didn't have that pinkish hue of fever on his face, his eyes weren't glassy, and his skin wasn't burning. Maybe he *was* better, and maybe being so overprotective of him was starting to get weird. To the both of them.

"Fine", Katsuki grumbled, relaxing on his seat. "Suit yourself".

He grabbed his phone again, sighing.

From: Katsuki Bakugou

His fever's broken, but I'll keep an eye on him.

From: Deku's Mom

Thank you, Katsuki-kun! I can only thank the heavens you're in there with my Izuku. If he was alone, I would find a way to go over there across all this snow to pick him up.

From: Deku's Mom

It's like you've become his guardian angel!

Katsuki rolled his eyes so hard he almost managed to see his own brain. Instead of responding, he locked the phone's screen, setting it aside and standing up.

"You done?", he nodded at Izuku's bowl. The boy nodded, and Katsuki picked it up along with his own, heading for the kitchen.

"You were talking with my mom?", Izuku asked, following him.

"Yeah".

"Uh… Why?"

"Did you tell her you were with me?", Katsuki gave him an unimpressed look as he ran the sink and began to wash the bowls.

"Uh… Yeah?"

"Then she was making sure you weren't lying".

"Oh".

"Yeah. Mommy knows you're a reckless piece of shit who lies about being safe".

Izuku blushed.

"I'm not a liar. I just don't like to make her worry over nothing".

“Given that you almost get yourself killed every other week, I can’t really blame her for worrying so much”.

“You’re one to talk”.

“Oh, yeah, because I’m definitely as reckless as you”.

“Of course you are”.

“I’m not”.

“Yes, you are”.

“Yeah? Tell me *one* reckless thing I’ve ever fucking done”.

“You…”, Izuku hesitated. “You… You used your Howitzer in a closed environment!”

Katsuki paled, but kept on doing the dishes while wearing an unperturbed façade.

“And you know that *how*?”

“Uh…”, Izuku hesitated again, awkward. “Well. Kirishima-kun told me”.

“*Kirishima-kun* knows shit”, Katsuki said, trying to diffuse the tension, but it was too late. They were back at *that* subject.

“I wanted to know what happened to your ear”.

“And why didn’t you ask me directly?”

Izuku bit his lower lip.

“I had just woken up. I didn’t know where we were standing, uh, re… Relationship-wise. I didn’t know if that was a subject you wanted to address”.

“So you asked someone else about it”.

“Yes”.

A pause.

“I’m sorry”.

“It’s *fine*. It doesn’t really bother me anymore”.

“Oh. I was worried about that”.

“Tch. Why?”

“Well… You did lose your hearing. I was afraid you weren’t coping really well, but I didn’t really know how to talk to you about it. I didn’t really know how to talk about *anything* at

that time – m-my stuttering was really bad".

"Well, thank fuck it's better now".

"Yes. Speech therapy really helped".

"Hm. I guess so".

"Yes".

An awkward silence.

"You know… We…", Izuku hesitated. Katsuki resumed doing the dishes and dried his hands.

"What?", he asked, standing directly in front of Izuku.

"We can still use sign language", Izuku shrugged. "If you want to. I haven't used it so much recently because I'm trying to practice talking more, but I didn't stop studying it. I… I didn't know how to ask you about your hearing, so I thought a nice way to show you I was there for you was to learn sign language".

Katsuki stared down at Izuku. His chest felt warm, his palms felt sweaty. There was a tingle at the tip of his fingers.

"If you feel like using sign language, then use it", Katsuki shrugged after thinking for a while. "If you feel like talking, then talk. It's not a big deal for me, I just learned it out of necessity".

He walked out of the kitchen. Deku followed him.

"A-All right", the boy agreed.

They both sat down on the sofa. Izuku awkwardly grabbed his joystick, but didn't press play or go back to the game. He anxiously looked up at Katsuki, a silent invitation in his eyes.

Fuck it. They were stuck together for the night, he had nothing better to do. He might as well indulge in this.

"Where's the second joystick?", he asked.

The smile that beamed in Izuku's face made his stomach churn. *Gross,* Katsuki thought to himself.

Izuku handed Katsuki the second joystick before grabbing the tip of his cover, which was now splayed on his lap, and waving at Katsuki suggestively.

"What?", Katsuki asked, frowning from where he was sitting at the opposite end of the couch.

"Aren't you cold?", Izuku asked.

“Of course I’m fucking cold, there’s a snow storm outside”, he scoffed. Izuku raised his eyebrows and nodded at his cover.

“You can share the cover with me”, he offered innocently. Katsuki scowled.

“Your icky *fever cover*? No, thanks, I’d rather freeze”, he scoffed.

“It’s not icky, Kacchan”, Izuku rolled his eyes. “And my fever isn’t contagious. It’s just because of my immune system”.

Katsuki kept scowling at him without offering a response.

“All right”, Izuku shrugged, letting go of the cover and grabbing his joystick. “Suit yourself”.

He pressed play and went back to the game, now with Katsuki as a second player.

“I can’t believe you suck so much at such a simple game”.

“Kacchan, for the millionth time, I’m just playing to train my coordination”, Izuku sighed, nudging Katsuki’s side with his elbow. “Stop mocking me”.

“*You* stop using excuses and just own up to the fact that you *suck*”, Katsuki scoffed, making an exaggerated gesture with his joystick and nudging Deku’s side back in the process. After shivering a lot of times and downright starting to shake, Katsuki had agreed to share Deku’s stupid cover with him – which meant he had to seat right beside Deku on the couch, since the cover couldn’t reach his end of it.

Tch. What a fucking mess of a situation. Not that Katsuki felt *really* annoyed about it, but he liked pretending that he felt.

~~(Plus, the cover kind of smelled like Deku)~~

“Why did we never do this before?”, Izuku asked excitedly, eyes glued on the screen.

“Because your lame ass knew I would be so much better than you, you subconsciously convinced yourself it was not worth trying”, Katsuki scoffed, an obnoxious smirk on his lips.

“Har har. Very funny, Kacchan”.

“I know”.

“Shut up”.

“You shut up, nerd”.

They continued to play together, mocking and teasing each other in a way that was friendly, and intimate, and that they had never done before. For the first time in a long while, that everlasting melancholy didn’t sit at the bottom of Katsuki’s stomach, and when he checked Deku for fever again, he was relieved to find that the boy’s temperature was back to normal.

It felt like they could both allow themselves to be ok, if only for a little while, as if the world didn’t exist beyond that common room, that sofa, that shared cover. As the storm raged on outside, Katsuki and Izuku continued to play the videogame and tease each other, as if they were finally finding the long-lost friendship that had been ripped from them at such an early age, out of their own fault. And as they inevitably fell asleep, right there on the common room’s couch, leaning against each other, it felt like everything would finally fall into place.

If only things were that simple.

“There is no time! It has to be now!”, Recovery Girl shouted, her arms filled with equipment as she rushed towards her patient.

All Might grabbed Katsuki by the shoulders, turning him towards him and staring deep into his eyes with a serious, assertive look.

“It has to be you, shonen. He trusted you. He needs you”.

“No –“

“You’re the only one of us who has his consent. If you don’t take it from him, it will kill him”.

“I’m losing him!”, Recovery Girl screamed as Deku began to flatline. Katsuki’s eyes widened in utter shock.

Deku was dying. His heart had stopped.

“Bakugou shonen!”, All Might roared, and Katsuki couldn’t remember ever hearing the man’s voice sound so powerful and authoritarian in his life, not even as he fought against the worst of villains.

He looked at Deku. His eyes were rolled back, his lips parted and coated in blood. His chest wasn’t moving.

His heart wasn’t beating.

Katsuki’s body responded before he could put much thought into it, before he could properly weight the consequences of what he was about to do. He shrugged away from All Might’s hands, surged forwards, grabbed Deku’s hair, yanked out a streak, shoved it into his mouth, and swallowed it.

He didn’t have the time or state of mind to think about how gross that was. All he could do was stare at Deku, dead on the hospital bed, bony and thin and eyes sunken into his skull-like face. This was the first time Katsuki had seen his body ever since the quirk accident, the first time he had seen it in a month, and now he understood why the boy had been so distraught upon seeing his own body.

He looked like a shell of himself. Like a ghost, like a skeleton, like a fucking goddamn corpse already.

Recovery Girl pushed Katsuki away from the bed with mindless strength and climbed on the top of Deku with a defibrillator. After two attempts that felt like they had lasted an eternity, she managed to urge a heartbeat back into the boy. Sighing in a relief that didn’t last too long, she started to give the nurses who had arrived all sorts of commands, all sorts of instructions, but Katsuki couldn’t hear them – not only because his hearing was now impaired, but because he was in shock. That was the only way to describe it. He was in pure, utter shock.

All Might was holding him and talking to him, but he couldn’t hear the words. All he could do was stare at Deku, who was lying still on the bed, who still looked dead despite of the heart monitor telling them otherwise. The crimson escaping his lips matched the crimson of Katsuki’s eyes, and he coughed up pitifully, painfully, still choking on his own blood as he was brought back to life.

And Katsuki had never felt so young, had never felt so vulnerable, had never felt so painfully aware of his own mortality than when he stared down at Deku on that moment, because Deku had just died, for less than a minute, yes, but Katsuki could have lost him forever and the last he would have ever seen of the boy would be… this. No more comments during class. No more compliments and praises. No more rivalry and competition. No more green eyes and soft smiles. No more ‘Kacchan’s, no more ‘matte yo!’s, no more ‘sugoi’s, no more Deku.

The thought scared him. He hated it that it did, but it scared him.

"Kacchan…"

"I need you to get out of here", he thought he heard Recovery Girl say through the blurry layer of shock that was coating his senses. "He's already been exposed enough. You shouldn't be here without the suits –"

"Come on, shonen", All Might's voice echoed. "We need to go".

"Did it work?", Katsuki heard himself say, but couldn't remember giving his brain the command to do so. His eyes were glued to Deku, and he turned his head to look at the boy's still form over his shoulder as All Might pushed him towards the door.

"Come on".

"Did it work?"

"We won't know for a while. But he's alive, and Recovery Girl needs to work –"

"Is it with me now? Did I take it?", he looked at All Might, eyes still wide, breath still caught in his throat.

"Kacchan…"

All Might squeezed his shoulder, looking pale.

"Did I take it from him?"

"You saved his life".

Katsuki gasped, face torn in a mixture of angry and horrified. He didn't feel any different after taking Deku's quirk – all he could feel was his racing heart and his constricted lungs.

Deku had died. He had fucking flatlined.

He had fucking died. He was coughing up blood. He was fucked up, and Katsuki had taken his quirk, and he was fucked up. And he had died.

"Kacchan…"

"Kacchan…"

"Kacchan!"

Usually, when Katsuki woke up from a nightmare, he woke up kicking and throwing punches, like a wounded animal desperately trying to escape. Now, all he did was snap his eyes open, sucking in a gasp and looking around, trying to recognize his surroundings, trying to make sense of what was happening. Because Deku was dead, he had died, he… He was…

He was… right above Katsuki, brow furrowed in deep worry, arms holding Katsuki's shoulders down.

The room was dark. The only source of light illuminating Deku's face was coming from the still turned-on TV. They had probably fallen asleep before turning it off.

He stared at Deku. The boy was still holding him, as if afraid Katsuki would hurt himself if he let go. He had never seen such concern directed towards him in a person's eyes.

"Get off me", was the first thing Katsuki said, hating how hoarse and rude his own voice sounded. Izuku immediately obeyed, letting go of Katsuki's shoulders and sitting back down on the couch as if to give him space without going too far.

"Are you ok?", Izuku asked as Katsuki forced himself into a sitting position. His hands were hovering nearby, as if he wanted to touch Katsuki but didn't quite knew how to. Katsuki ran a tired hand across his tired face.

"Yeah", Katsuki said without looking at him.

"Did you have a nightmare?", Izuku asked again, fidgety. Katsuki sighed, angry.

"What do you think?"

A pause. It was evident that Katsuki's mood wasn't faring so well, given how grumpy he seemed to be out of a sudden. Deku moved, awkwardly standing up from the couch and grabbing his phone. Katsuki didn't look at him, and the nerd simply stood there for a moment, as if trying to make a decision.

"I'll… I'll go back to my room", he announced, voice low as if he didn't want to startle Katsuki. "You… I think you want some space, and I don't want to – to – you know", he trailed off. Upon Katsuki's silence, he completed the thought: "Make you… angry".

Silence. Katsuki sat unmoving, hunched over, his elbows leaning on his knees and closed eyes leaning on his hands. Deku's cover was covering only one of his legs, now, and the boy seemed ok with leaving it behind. To keep Katsuki warm. When *he* was the fucking sick one.

Enough was enough.

Katsuki couldn't keep doing this. Deku had always been nice to him, nicer than he deserved. Katsuki had spent so long mistaking that niceness for condescendence, he had spent so long mistaking Deku's altruism for contempt. He had spent so long messing up. Deku deserved to know that Katsuki had his quirk. He deserved to know that Katsuki, the one who always teased him and mistreated him and put him down for being quirkless, was the one who had made him quirkless again.

Deku deserved to know the truth.

Upon Katsuki's silence, Izuku started to move, ready to leave the room.

"Deku", Katsuki called. The boy immediately stopped on his tracks.

“Yes?”, he called. His voice was so small. *He* was so small. And bony. And weak. All because he took that blow in Katsuki’s place all those months ago. All because he had put his life aside for *him*.

He had died… he was dead, he had… His heart stopped –

Katsuki said nothing.

“Do you want me to stay?”, Izuku asked, because he knew Katsuki couldn’t say the words himself. He couldn’t ask for it.

A simple nod was all it took for him to make his way back to the couch, sitting right beside Katsuki.

“Is it ok if I touch you?” Izuku asked, hesitant. Katsuki nodded again, not looking at him.

Izuku passed an arm around Katsuki’s trembling shoulders, offering him comfort. They were silent.

Until Katsuki wasn’t.

“I have your quirk”.

The soothing hand Deku was rubbing on Katsuki’s back came to an abrupt stop.

An eternity passed.

“What?”

“One For All. It’s with me, now”.

Silence.

“I just… I can’t keep hiding it from you. It’s fucking driving me *crazy*”.

Silence.

“You were dying, and you’d given me permission. You don’t remember it, but you had. I didn’t… *steal* it, or whatever it is you’re thinking. I was – I was just trying to save your life”.

He removed his hands from his eyes, turning his head softly to the side in order to look at Izuku.

The boy’s face was impassive. Katsuki wouldn’t be able to comprehend the emotions in his green eyes if he tried for a hundred years.

“When the villain attacked us, his quirk – it detached souls from their bodies. I still have no clue what went wrong that day, but, when he hit you, he was supposed to have kept your soul for himself. But it ended up with me instead”.

Izuku’s eyes were fixed on him.

“Your soul was bound to mine for a month. I was the only one who could see you, touch you and talk to you. When we ambushed the villain in the sewers, he separated us”.

Silence.

“When he did that, you… You realized what was happening and tried to pass One For All to me. But you couldn’t do it, because the villain had already undone the soulbond. Then I blew him to hell, and I almost killed him, and I managed to deafen myself in the process”.

Silence.

“When they got your soul back into your body, it was too weak to sustain One For All. Since you had given me permission, I took it”.

Silence.

“It was to save your life. I didn’t have a choice, Deku, it – You were dying, you were coughing up blood, your heart stopped. I didn’t have a choice”.

Silence.

“I didn’t want it. I didn’t *fucking want it*”.

Silence.

“So I’m going to give it back, as soon as you’re well enough to take it”.

Silence.

It stretched on for so long, Katsuki began to wonder if he had lost the hearing in his good ear, too.

“So… I’m quirkless again?”

Katsuki sighed, eyes fixed on Izuku’s. *Face your problems head on, lest they swallow you whole.*

“Yes”.

Silence.

“Do you…”

A pause.

“Do you even know if a previous holder of One For All can take it back after giving it up?”

Katsuki felt himself pale up. He didn’t say anything.

All Might had said he could give the quirk back to Deku later, right? He wouldn’t have lied about that.

Unless he was really *that* desperate to save Deku's life?

Upon his silence, Deku's hand was gone from his back, the sudden cold of its absence making the previous warmth of its touch more evident.

"Is that why you've been so nice to me?", Izuku asked, suddenly defensive. "Because you feel *guilty* for making me quirkless again?"

Katsuki stared at him.

"What? No –"

"Then why didn't you tell me before?", the boy interrupted, and what hurt the most was he didn't even sound angry, or pissed, or hurt – he sounded *scared*. He sounded terrified, and it was Katsuki's fault. He should have kept his mouth shut. He hadn't expected that reaction – "If you really can give it back to me when I'm better, then why – why didn't you *say* –"

"Deku".

Izuku stood up from the couch, hands shaking, breath catching in his throat. He looked distraught.

"I…", he hesitated, panicking.

Katsuki stared at him.

"I need to think".

Katsuki didn't say anything.

He felt, more than heard, Deku walk out of the common room. He left the cover behind, but it felt more like forgetfulness than an actual effort to keep Katsuki warm or comfort him. It felt wrong for Katsuki to touch it or even use it, so he tossed it aside to the farthest corner of the couch and lied down as far away as possible from it, throwing an arm over his eyes.

Deku did look like he was dying, blood tinging his lips and his cheeks red while he choked on it, eyes squeezed shut in agony. The crimson contrasted greatly with the whiteness of his face.

But still, Katsuki couldn't – he couldn't just take it, he couldn't steal his damn quirk –

"You said before he tried to pass it to you. That means you have his consent –", All Might continued.

"No, I fucking don't –", Katsuki panted, furious, angry, because how the fuck could All Might even suggest something like that to him?! After everything he had done to Deku because he was quirkless? After the asshole finally got a damn fucking quirk in the first place?

Katsuki closed his eyes.

Deku was alive. And the only reason he was alive was because Katsuki had taken One For All.

(He could only hope Deku would reach the same conclusion, eventually).

But thinking back on it, and thinking back on all the steps that led him down this path, Katsuki came to the conclusion that, if it came down to it, would do it all over again. He would rather have Deku hate him than be dead.

Still, that realization did nothing to ease the weight that was forming on the pit of his stomach, making it sink uncomfortably, squeezing the air out of his lungs.

(At least, the weight was no longer on his shoulders).

The roads were cleared in the morning, which meant Inko managed to get to UA along with All Might in order to pick Izuku up and take him home.

Katsuki didn't even see him go. The boy had taken the elevator, and, even if Katsuki *had* seen him, he wouldn't have gone after him. Why would he? If Deku had wanted to bid him goodbye, he *would* have. If Deku had wanted to see him one last time before their school break began, he would have.

If Deku had wanted to tell him he hated him to his face, he would have.

(Katsuki sort of wished he did. Hate was better than apathy, that was his experience so far.)

But Deku did none of those things. And when Katsuki went back to his room in the morning, Izuku was already gone, leaving him in the dark as to what he was feeling and thinking about everything that he had learned on the previous night.

Katsuki packed his shit with newfound apathy and grabbed his phone. No new texts.

From: Brat

On my way

From: Old Hag

Already?

From: Brat

Why, you want me to stay here fucking longer?

From: Old Hag

I thought you were only coming over at night, I’m not home

From: Brat

So fucking what

From: Old Hag

Do you have the keys?

From: Brat

Yeah

From: Old Hag

Ok then

From: Old Hag

But your dad and I will only be back at night

From: Brat

Whatever

Katsuki threw his bag over his shoulder and headed out. He didn’t bother to take a final look at his dorm bedroom, where he had shared a month and a soul with Deku, lest the memories of what he lost overwhelm him even more.

Chapter End Notes

This took forever, so I made it extra long.

It's fun to write Katsuki. He's really hard to write, but I like exploring his emotions and the psychological side of him we don't see much in canon. Given the choices he had to make and the path he took in this story, I'd say he's getting a bit better, but he needs time.
(I'm also a fan of anxious!Bakugou without realizing he's anxious, so...)

Life's been crazy, man. Life's been crazy. I'm trying my best, though, 'cause I love writing this story and I love that you guys like it so much. As for the original plan for the number of chapters - blow it to hell. There's more on the way, I'm just not sure how I'll divide it yet.

I hope this turned out ok. Wanted to explore more of Bakugou's and Jirou's relationship (accidental-cockblocker Bakugou too, if you're into Momojirou). Also wanted to explore his feeling of isolation - you know, none of his friends before UA were legit and all that jazz. His and Izuku's experiences of isolation are pretty different, and I think of Bakugou as a guy who isolates himself (not always on purpose), whereas Izuku is a guy who gets isolated by others (the poor thing). Anyway. I like diving into these sorts of parallels, and I like making Bakugou more... human? Idk. I'm tying my best over here.

Anyway. I'll try to update faster than last time, because I have some pretty exciting stuff in store for the next chapters. I hope you guys dig it too! But no promises, because now I work full-time and University is back to bite me in the ass. I barely have time to write anymore, but rest assured: I am NOT abandoning this story. I really want to finish it.

Well, you guys are great. See you next time, and thank you for being so patient!

(P.S.: Lowkey stressed out about what you guys will think of Deku's reaction, but I tried to make it as human/realistic/reasonable-despite-the-circumstances as possible. Please BEAR WITH ME GUYS both of them are stubborn oblivious idiots with unresolved issues but they WILL get their shit together)

Chapter 20: Wouldn't Want to Know

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Katsuki was standing in the middle of his kitchen, face stoic but head banging subtly along with the rhythm of the song he was blasting on his phone. With one hand, he carefully grasped the handle of a pan that sat above the fire of the stove; with the other, he stirred the breakfast he was cooking for himself.

“Katsuki!”, Mitsuki screamed at the top of his lungs from her bedroom upstairs. Katsuki didn’t hear her – not only was he not wearing his hearing aid, but the music he was blasting was way too loud for his good ear to pick up the voice of his mother coming from so far.

He continued to cook, turning off the stove once his breakfast was fried enough and then crouching down, face as impassive (and slightly grumpy) as ever, to check how the cake he had baked was faring inside the oven. It was almost ready – it would only need around ten more minutes in the heat before it was perfect.

“*Katsuki*!”, Mitsuki screamed again, louder this time, but Katsuki remained none-the-wiser. The song he was listening to merged into another one, and once again Katsuki found himself baffled by Ears’ ability to make playlists. He wouldn’t dare to thank her again, since he didn’t want to inflate her ego even more, but he could admit, at least to himself, that the girl was damn *good*.

He sat by the kitchen table and nibbled at his fuming breakfast as he waited for the cake to get ready. He wasn’t feeling all that hungry, but the new diet he was getting himself into required him not to skip fucking meals, so there he was. He tapped his foot rhythmically on the floor as he chewed, sparing a glance towards the oven to check on his cake.

“Katsuki *fucking* Bakugou!”, Mitsuki screamed once again, and, this time, there was no way Katsuki couldn’t have heard her – she appeared at the kitchen’s door, her hair an unruly mess and still wild from sleep, her pajamas disheveled, and her face furious. She unceremoniously grabbed Katsuki’s phone and, before he could say anything, she turned the music off, slamming the device back on the table with force once she was done.

“What the *fuck* are you doing?!”, Katsuki stood up from his chair, annoyed. He snatched his phone away from his mother and glared at her, already feeling the anger he was trying so hard to suppress starting to warm up inside his veins.

“What the fuck are *you* doing?”, his mother retorted, her voice loud. “It’s 7 in the fucking morning, why the hell are you blasting that shit so loudly in my house?”

“Why the fuck are you still asleep at *7 in the fucking morning*?”, Katsuki shouted back. A sleepy Masaru appeared in the hallway outside the kitchen, hair equally messy and face discernably confused.

“Because it’s what you’re supposed to fucking do at a fucking weekend, dipshit! And stop fucking talking back to me!”, Mitsuki hollered.

“Guys, what’s going on?”, Masaru slurred, rubbing at his glassless eyes. He sounded tired.

“You don’t come to my fucking kitchen turning off my fucking music and shouting at my face and tell me not to fucking talk back to you –“

“Oh, it’s *your* kitchen? Did you fucking pay for it?”

“The fuck are you talking about? This has always been my house too, just because I moved into UA doesn’t mean I don’t have the fucking right to cook my damn breakfast and listen to my shit –”

“Now you fucking listen here you damn brat –“

“No, *you* fucking listen, old hag –“

“As long as you live under my fucking roof without putting money into it, you’re going to live by my fucking rules, and that includes not blasting this shit while I’m trying to get some damn sleep! You don’t like it, die fucking mad about it!”

“Mitsuki, let’s calm down for a bit, ok? I know you’re stressed out –“

“Shut the hell up! Don’t undermine my authority just because you have a soft spot for him! He needs to learn he can’t get away with pulling this sort of shit –“

“*Mitsuki*”, Masaru placed both hands on the woman’s shoulders, forcing her to face him. He still looked tired, but more sober now, as if seeing his wife and his son getting into such an intense argument had forced him to fully wake up. “I’ll talk to Katsuki. Go back upstairs and get some rest. Ok?”

Mitsuki stared up at her husband, still angry. She batted his hands away from her shoulders, turning to glare at Katsuki again. The boy had sat back down at the kitchen table, but he was glaring back defiantly at his mother, ready to restart their argument if needed.

“If I hear any more of this shitty depressing music you’ve been playing”, she said sternly, “I’ll throw your damn phone in the toilet and flush it”.

“You can try”, Katsuki scoffed. Mitsuki raised her eyebrows and took a menacing step towards her son, but Masaru stepped between them, holding his wife in place again.

“Honey. Please”, he said, calm. “Let me talk to him”.

Mitsuki scoffed and shrugged away from her husband’s touch once more. This time, however, she complied to his request and headed back upstairs, not without sending one final angry glare at Katsuki before she went.

“As if I could ever get some rest in this fucking house”, she muttered through gritted teeth as she climbed the stairs with heavy steps.

Masaru's shoulders sagged as soon as his wife was out of view and he sighed heavily, pinching the bridge of his nose between two fingers before he turned back to Katsuki, who was still sitting by the kitchen table with an angry expression on his face.

Without saying anything, Masaru took the seat in front of his son and gave him a melancholic look.

"I thought the anger therapy was helping", was the first thing he said, a mixture of disappointment and reprehension in his voice, which honestly wasn't the wisest approach to the fuming, straight-out-of-an-argument-with-his-mom Katsuki.

"You're telling that to *me*? The old hag's the one who fucking *needs* the damn anger thera–"

"Katsuki", Masaru interrupted him sternly before he could go any further, his voice stricter than usual. "I understand you're angry, but you will *not* talk about your mother like that".

"Oh, so she can call me dipshit and asshole and brat and whatever the hell she wants but I can't call her an old hag?", he scoffed with annoyance.

"Yes".

"And that's fair *how*?"

"It's not. But she is your mother, and you owe her respect".

"I owe her shit", Katsuki scoffed, looking away from his father.

"*Katsuki*".

"It's true".

There was a beat.

"It's her fault I'm like this".

Silence. He could feel his father's eyes glued to him, but couldn't bring himself to meet his gaze.

"I know your mother is a difficult person", Masaru said with a heavy sigh after it became clear Katsuki wasn't about to say anything else. "And I know the way she raised you – the way *we* raised you – wasn't exactly… optimal. To you. But you need to understand she loves you".

"Tch".

"She does, Katsuki. And so do I. And we know you love us too, even if you have your own way of showing it. She needs to work on her temper, that's true, but… Everything she does – all this yelling and arguing and fighting – it's because she cares".

"Tch. Yeah".

“I mean it”.

“What a nice fucking way of showing it, eh?”, he finally glared at his father, resentment evident in his crimson eyes.

“Everyone has a unique way of showing love”, Masaru told him patiently. “And while I do agree that Mitsuki needs to learn how to be less aggressive, you don’t exactly make things easy on her, either”.

“So you’re saying this is my fucking fault?”, Katsuki asked, indignant.

“It’s nobody’s fault”, he sighed, rubbing a tired hand on his face. “But did you really need to blast your music so loudly at 7 a.m.?”

Katsuki scoffed again, facing away from his father. Masaru leaned forwards on the table.

“Look, son”, he sighed, honest. “We’ve just… We’ve been having a hard time at work”, he admitted.

Katsuki looked at him, masking his surprise behind a hostile expression. He waited for his father to continue.

“Usually, the end of the year is when we make top sales, but… the economy isn’t great right now, competition has been growing, and a lot of those companies have been investing on marketing and product placement and are managing to outsell us. Our income this month was nowhere close to last year’s, and…”, he sighed again. “Let’s just say we’ve both been working a lot, and earned less money for it. It’s been… difficult. And you know how your mom is – she’s stressed out and angry even in her best days, let alone on her worse”.

Katsuki swallowed dry, feeling his stomach grow heavy with something very close to guilt. He glanced at his father.

“I didn’t know”, he admitted. His face still looked angry, but his tone was the slightest bit softer.

“I know you didn’t. Because we didn’t tell you”.

Katsuki shook his head in disapproval and betrayal.

“Why not? I could have done something. I could have –“

“No”, Masaru interrupted him firmly. He reached forwards across the table and grabbed one of Katsuki’s hand. Usually, the boy would have shrugged away from the touch, but these days Katsuki was getting whatever little comfort he could get. “You’ve got enough on your plate as it is. This year has been harsh, on all of us, but it has been especially harsh on you”.

Katsuki looked away again, glaring at the wall. His father gave him a sympathetic look.

“We didn’t want you to worry about this over everything else, that’s why we didn’t tell you. But that also means we’ve been carrying this with us this whole time, and, again… You know

how your mom is".

Katsuki scoffed, and the sound almost resembled a tiny chuckle.

"Like a fucking timebomb", he provided. His father smiled and nodded.

"Yes. She's not great at this. And… Of course we're not complaining, you're our son and we miss you, but…"

Masaru didn't finish the thought. Katsuki met his eyes again, squinting.

"What?"

His father sighed.

"You've been spending a lot of time at home".

Katsuki could feel his face close itself up like an oyster in a defensive gesture – an impassive mask he always put on whenever a subject hit too close to home.

"And it's not that we don't like having you here, son, but your mom – she's just worried. She doesn't know how to show it, but she is. You've never been a stay-at-home kid. Before UA, you were always going out with your friends and hanging out and studying somewhere else. Having you here all the time makes her – and me, too –… a bit… *edgy*. It makes us think that there's something wrong, but she doesn't know how to help. That's why she snapped at you".

"Not a great way of fucking helping", Katsuki muttered.

"Not a great way, no", Masaru nodded. "But I don't know if my way helps, either. Do you want to tell me what's wrong?"

Katsuki looked away, swallowing dry.

He was silent for a while before shaking his head no, glaring daggers at the kitchen table.

Masaru nodded in comprehension, squeezing Katsuki's hand before letting go and leaning back against his seat.

"Is there any way I can help? Make things a bit better?", he asked. Katsuki exhaled sharply through his nose, feeling frustrated.

"Nah", he crossed his arms above his chest, not looking at his father.

"Are you sure?", Masaru insisted, sounding concerned. "It could be anything. Just name it".

Katsuki looked at him. His father looked genuinely worried about him, and also willing to help. And, as ridiculous as that sounded, Katsuki felt like he didn't deserve all that attention in the face of everything else his folks were facing. He was strong, he was resilient, he was fucking capable of dealing with his own shit without needing anybody's help.

“Yeah. I’ll be fine, I’m just…”, he sighed. “Trying to figure some shit out”.

Masaru nodded his understanding.

“Well, if you need anything – even if it’s just to talk”, he said, offering Katsuki a tired smile. “You can always count on me, ok?”

Katsuki scoffed, offering his father a teasing smirk.

“Cheesy”.

“Stop it”, Masaru told him with humor as he stood up from the kitchen table. “Are you baking another cake?”

“Yeah”, Katsuki replied, well aware that his father was probably wondering why he seemed so fond of baking cakes recently. In reality, the whole process helped him distract himself, and this was about the fifth or sixth caked he cooked in a few days.

“Hmm”, Masaru hummed. “Save me a slice for later?”

“K”, Katsuki nodded, not looking up at his father.

“I’ll try to catch some more sleep, all right?”, Masaru told him. “We’ve been really tired recently, and well… Weekends are about the only time we can get our energies back”.

“I’ll keep the music down”, was Katsuki’s only reply.

Masaru nodded his thanks before heading out of the kitchen but, before he could exit, Katsuki said:

“Hey”.

Masaru stopped on his tracks, looking at his soon. Katsuki didn’t look at him, his eyes fixed on his own hands resting atop the kitchen table as he spoke.

“Sorry for waking you up. That was shitty of me”.

Masaru was silent for a few seconds, and Katsuki didn’t know what sort of look was painting his father’s face. He didn’t look.

“It’s ok, son”, Masaru said, his voice sounding soft and mostly shocked. Only then did Katsuki realize this was probably the first time his father had ever heard him apologize for anything with sincerity, and without being ordered to do so. He wondered what Doctor Matsuo would think of that development.

It took him a special effort *not* to wonder what Deku would think of that development.

“Just wanted you to know”, Katsuki shrugged, still avoiding his father’s eyes.

There was a pause.

“Thank you, Katsuki”, Masaru said eventually, his voice sounding emotional, and, oh, shit, Katsuki hoped to *god* the old man wasn’t about to cry over a freaking *apology*.

“Yeah”, Katsuki shrugged again in a way that told him the conversation was over, before standing up and checking on his damn cake. Masaru went upstairs without saying anything else, but if Katsuki had been wearing his hearing aid, he may have managed to pick up the soft sniffing sounds that were coming from his father hunched over figure.

He lied on his bed in the dark, the only source of light in the room coming from the bluish screen of his phone illuminating his face. He had ignored all of Kirishima’s, Kaminari’s, Mina’s, and Sero’s texts inviting him to all different sort of holiday programs in favor of staring fixedly at the one text that still kept him up at night (amongst other things).

From: Deku

We need to talk

Read at: December 15

Katsuki stared at the text. It had arrived four days before, and he had offered no sort of response to it. To be fair with himself, he couldn’t tell whether it was out of a childish pettiness for being dumped by Deku like that, or if it was still out of avoidance of the boy’s reaction.

Deku knew the truth now. And… Well. He hadn’t reacted all too well to it. Katsuki knew Deku’s reaction had been nowhere near as bad as it *could* have been, but he also knew that he’d much rather have the boy scream at him and hate him and resent him than have him ignore him like that. Deku’s indifference was a million times worse than his hatred, and Katsuki didn’t know what he would do if the boy told him that he never wanted to see him again.

Wasn’t that a fucked-up thought? Not knowing what he would do should *Deku*, shitty, stupid Deku didn’t want to look at his face?

He once again felt like he was betraying himself for feeling so worried about what Deku thought of him. Who cared?! Why should *he* care? This was *Deku*. Stupid, idiot Deku who

had only ever been a nuisance, who had only ever annoyed him and pissed him off and fucking made him want to punch something. Katsuki shouldn't give a shit about what the nerd thought. So Deku was fucking mad Katsuki had saved his life? That was *his* damn problem. Once the fucker was well enough to take his damn quirk back and put an end to this shitty story, Katsuki would have no remaining connection to him. And even if Deku remembered everything from his time as a bodiless soul, even if he finally came to understand why Katsuki had done what he did, that still wouldn't mean Katsuki was under any sort of obligation to keep talking to him or to be his friend.

And that would be for the best, right? Ever since he bothered establishing a relationship with the shitty nerd, his life had gone to hell. He'd been feeling miserable as fuck. And it was way fucking easier to blame Deku for that than to think too hard about *why* he felt like shit.

And wasn't that what he had been doing his entire life? Blaming Deku for his problems, shoving the blame on him all the time, taking all his negative feelings out on him? Katsuki had told his dad that his mother was to blame for his angry temper, but at the end of the day, *Deku* was the one who had always gotten the worst of his rage.

It was past the time Katsuki stopped blaming the boy for mistakes that were his own.

He deflated. It was fair for Deku to be upset, or angry, or indifferent, or whatever the hell it was he was feeling. It was his right. Katsuki had taken One For All from him to save his life, but Katsuki had also bullied him and put him down and probably scarred him for life in some level. Taking One For All hadn't been optional – if he hadn't done it, Deku would have died. Bullying Deku for being quirkless, on the other hand, had been entirely his choice, and it was about time he acknowledged that.

Katsuki didn't know if he could ever make up for that. He knew he couldn't change it, but he wasn't so sure he could ever make it better. And even if, sometimes, he still had his doubts as to whether or not he should feel so bad about everything he had done, he also knew that he couldn't keep convincing himself he hadn't been in the wrong. He had hurt Deku, and it was only right Deku resented him for it.

But Deku had stayed. In every single moment of his life, Deku had been there.

And now Deku wasn't there anymore.

And the text he had sent… It could mean that he still wanted to be there. But it could also mean that he didn't, ever again.

And Katsuki hated himself for not wanting to find out. Because as long as he kept ignoring Deku, as long as he didn't reply to his shitty message, Deku wouldn't be able to tell him that he hated him, and that he despised him, and that he never wanted to see him again. As long as Katsuki didn't give the bastard an opening, an opportunity to tell him off, they would be in this limbo of a relationship, where they weren't friends, but weren't enemies, either.

If he had to be very honest, they were nothing. Nothing at all.

And this evasive attitude was driving Katsuki crazy, because running away like a coward was so unlike himself that it made him sick, but every other option he had in hands held the potential of resulting in Deku being driven away from him forever. And as hard as his brain was screaming *so what???* at him nonstop, Katsuki found that he had already gone through so much, he had already struggled so hard, that losing Deku at the end of everything, after watching him die and fighting for him, was just the worst-case scenario. Losing the *one constant* in his life would probably just send everything crumbling apart, and the thought was just unimaginable for him, no matter how ridiculous that felt.

Plus, they had lived exactly like this so far, hadn't they? Ignoring each other, not talking, not communicating, not even as much as glancing at each other. Katsuki could deal with it. He had dealt with it his whole life – hell, he had been the *cause* of it.

He didn't have an option, now. He had had one, back when they were just a pair of naïve quirkless brats playing and laughing in the park. But he didn't now.

And Deku hadn't sent any other texts, either. After that one attempt at reaching out, he had gone silent, and Katsuki couldn't help but to think back to a tiny child's hand reaching out for him, asking if he was ok, and his own hand slapping it away from himself in anger and disdain as he lay fallen on Deku's feet.

Maybe Deku hadn't tried to reach out again because he, too, knew, as well as Katsuki did, that half of something was better than nothing at all. It was better for their relationship to go back to its years-long cold, distant treatment, than to have no relationship whatsoever.

Because that was what would happen, wasn't it? It wasn't like Katsuki was under any sort of deluded impression that Deku was anywhere close to forgiving him for stealing his quirk, for making him quirkless. Even if Katsuki hadn't wanted it. Even if Katsuki only did it to save his shitty, ungrateful life.

He sighed. He couldn't help but to feel like the bitterness inside him was unjustified, because at the end of the day, this was what he deserved. He had built the very path that led him to this. He had dug the grave of his friendship with Deku on the very first day he thought it might be a good idea to pick on him.

Maybe they just weren't meant to talk to each other, or to be close to each other, or to be friends at all. Maybe they had *never* been meant to do that. Maybe all they were meant to be was… this. Former friends, former rivals, former… Whatever the hell else. But never something, in the present, in the moment. Never something constant.

Never something permanent.

He still needed to attend one final session with Doctor Matsuo before the time came for their winter break, since the woman could probably use the vacation time. But getting out of the house also meant risking meeting Deku, since they both lived at the same damn neighborhood and Katsuki's luck was apparently the fucking worst.

Katsuki wouldn't admit it to anyone, probably not even to himself, that the reason why he had been spending so much time at home – the reason why he was already driving his old woman crazy, and himself in the process – was because he didn't want to risk seeing Deku or Inko. He was pretty damn sure Deku would just act like he hadn't seen him if they happened to run into each other, but Inko – *fuck.*

Katsuki had no doubt in his mind that the woman would approach him, and try to talk to him, and probably even try to coax him into coming over and having a chat with her quirkless son over some tea and biscuits. And, if Katsuki denied, she would make *that face* and tell him the truths he didn't want to hear, and make him talk about things he didn't want to talk about, and overall be a pain in the ass and make him feel even worse. So, yeah, at the end of the day, it was better to stay at home minding his own business, studying, and improving his hero gear on his own than to bother going outside. It wasn't like he had anything better to do anyway.

(He tried not to think about all of his friends' constant invitations for him to hang out with them that were left with no reply in his inbox).

But this was getting too far now, and Katsuki felt ridiculous for just sitting at home listening to his mom's bullshit and getting into arguments with her every other ten minutes when he could be doing literally anything else.

They were both too explosive to handle being next to each other for too long – it had always been like that. Before UA, Katsuki would go out of his way to *not* be at home, since his mom was there more often than not. He would hang out with the leeches he used to call friends and who were drawn to him because of his quirk and his popularity, and whenever he wanted to study, he would do it somewhere else, just like his father had accused, because he had reached a point where locking himself up in his room and blasting loud music in his ears wouldn't do the trick of muffling the annoying sounds of his mom's complaints anymore.

But that had been a different time, and Katsuki had been a different person. Things had changed, now. He had actual friends, instead of just a bunch of greedy people who wanted attention and opportunities because of his quirk. He knew he could count on Kirishima, and on Kaminari, and on Mina, and on Sero, and even on Jirou, but he still couldn't bring himself to face them or meet them after everything that had happened.

It had been hard to be around them after the sewer fiasco; it was even harder now, after the distance he put between himself and Deku, because the fuckers *knew* how attached he had gotten to the nerd – quite literally. They *knew* that Katsuki had started to care about him, even if a little bit. And since they knew, they would feel entitled to ask him all sorts of questions about why he stopped talking to Deku, why he hadn't visited him during the winter break, why and why and why and lots of whys he didn't want to fucking answer or even think about.

And turns out his dad was right: there *was* a lot on his plate, and the only way he had ever learned to deal with his problems was alone.

That was his *modus operandi*, right? He'd always been a lone wolf. He'd always fared way better on his own than with the help of others, he'd never been a team worker. And he should keep things that way, right? He fucking should. He shouldn't allow this aspect of himself to change, like he had done with his anger, and with his manners, and with his feelings for Deku. He needed to grasp onto the last aspect of himself that still *felt* like himself; he had to cling to the only other familiar thing that had been in his life for as long as Deku had – his solitude.

Fuck. He felt like he was going insane, losing himself in a whirlwind of thoughts and insecurities and questions about himself. He *hated* it. Things were simpler when he was just angry.

But as much as solitude served to comfort him in a way, despite the overwhelming loneliness, Katsuki still couldn't say he was completely alone. That was because he was still fucking obliged to spill his problems onto a paid therapist, thanks to that shitshow that sent his fucking life into a downhill. And yes, he still preferred to think and refer to his sessions with Doctor Matsuo as an obligation, rather than a necessity, because this way it became easier to pretend that he didn't have to go unless he was forced to; that he didn't *need* Doctor Matsuo's assistance as long as it was being imposed to him. And fuck it if he was feeling terrible, and lonely, and miserable, and isolated – he had brought this upon himself. He had *chosen* it – he opted to ignore his friends' texts, he opted to stay at home listening to his mom's bullshit, he opted to not risk seeing shitty fucking Deku or his mom around at the street.

The place he was at was a direct result of his shitty choices. All of them. From kindergarten. From the first day he pushed Deku away. From the first day he looked at his peers and decided he was better than them, just because his *quirk* was better.

Katsuki could feel it inside him, the boiling, corrosive, defensive anger surfacing at the pit of his stomach, ready to bottle itself up until it was choking him from the inside out and spewing out of his mouth, making him spit venomous words and thoughts that he didn't really want to say anymore. Ever since he had started anger management – ever since he lost his hearing, and lost *Deku*, and had to sit by his bedside for a month and another month and *another month* –, Katsuki had managed to keep his angry feelings down, if not because he had Doctor Matsuo's help, then because he had a fucking *lot* to deal with. Back in those past months, he hadn't had the time to be angry – he was too busy feeling a fuckton of other things. Misery, and regret, and guilt, and frustration, and sadness, and an unbearable sense of longing – all of that had helped him put his rage aside, or smother it, in a way – reduce it to just a white noise at the back of his head.

But now? Now all he did was sit at home after Deku fucking walked out on him, too busy *making* himself busy, because pretending his fucking gear needed Update #189 in order to function properly and going over the same sign language class for the third time was better than stepping out of the house to hang out with Kirishima. It was better than having *Kirishima* come over, because the last thing he needed was to see the look of pity and sympathy in his best friend's eyes, the last thing he needed was for Kirishima to tell him he

was there for him, the last thing he needed was for Kirishima to approach that subject and try to make Katsuki talk about it or, worse, feel *better* about it. He didn't any of that crap. He could handle it on his own.

He fucking *had* to.

But he was still under the risk of being expelled and losing his damn license forevermore if he didn't attend to the shitty therapy, so maybe, for just one afternoon, he could fool himself into thinking that he didn't have to be so alone.

Thinking better about it, Katsuki came to realize that the thought of not *having* to be alone terrified him. Depending on others? Hah. What a fucking joke. What a terrifying, mortifying, terrible joke.

He changed clothes, grabbed his phone and his wallet, put on his hearing aid and headed out of his house with an unexpected surge of adrenaline. What was the worst thing that could happen if Deku or Inko were around, anyway? Would they stop him? Turn their noses up at him? Fuck if Katsuki cared. He was better off if he *didn't* care, if he forced himself not to care. Then he could just tell them to fuck off and then he'd never have to look at either of their faces again. And that would be for the best, right? His life would be a fuckton better with no Deku in it. From day one. Fuck Deku, and fuck Inko, and fuck their green, sad eyes. Katsuki didn't need them. Katsuki was better off without them.

That was what he kept telling himself as he walked out of the house without bidding his parents goodbye. He didn't need Deku. He had lived most of his life without being friends with him, he didn't need him. He didn't *need him*. Deku hated him and didn't want him around anymore, and he was *right* to, but it also gave Katsuki the right to hate him back and not want him around, either. Fuck his text asking to talk. Fuck his quirk. Fuck him. If Deku wanted to hate him, that was *fine*. That was totally, completely fine by Katsuki. It was Deku's loss, right?

Fuck him for being born without a quirk, fuck him for being so sensitive about everything, fuck him for trying to help everyone who needed help, fuck him for being so smart and dedicated, fuck him for loving All Might, fuck him for living in the same neighborhood as him, fuck him for saving him from the sludge villain even though he had no quirk, fuck him for getting into UA, fuck him for rescuing him from the League, fuck him for being around in every single key moment of Katsuki's fucking life, fuck him for caring so much, fuck him for being willing to give his life to save Katsuki's.

Fuck him. Just – fuck Deku. Stupid, useless, fucking Deku who wouldn't save his own life if it meant risking others'. Idiot Deku who jumps in front of an incoming attack to save the life of a guy who made his life hell. Fuck Deku for hating him, even though he had good reason to.

Katsuki knew Deku was right to be angry, but that didn't mean he couldn't resent him for it. If anything, resenting Deku was natural to him – he had spent his entire life doing just that. It was second nature.

By the time he arrived at Doctor Matsuo's office, he was shaking and gritting his teeth. His anger was evident and she didn't have to look at him twice to realize her patient was about to explode into a fit at any given moment. He walked into the room silently, allowed himself to drop to the couch, and anxiously bounced his leg up and down in an annoying rhythm until the woman was sitting right in front of him with a mildly concerned look.

And before she could ask him what was wrong, or worse, how his week had been (which was the question Katsuki hated the most), he was spilling everything to her: spending the night at the dorm with Deku during the storm, their confrontation (even though he didn't mention One For All), the week of isolation, his mom pissing the hell out of him, his dad revealing they were going through financial problems, every single fucking thing that might have contributed to how shitty he was feeling. By the time he was done, he had thrown several coins on his swear jar, his hands shaking and his lower lip quivering from the fury he was still experiencing and the relief of having let it all out at last.

Doctor Matsuo stared at him. He took a series of deep breaths and ran a shaky hand across his face. If he was being forced to do this, he might as well get something out of it – the relief of finally saying (almost) everything he wanted to say without fearing being judged for it. The woman had seen him in a state way worse than bitching about his problems.

"Ok, that gives us a lot to work with", she said with an impressed look, still studying Katsuki with attention in her sharp eyes. She shifted on her seat, never breaking eye contact. "I'd like to start with something, though, since this is our last session in a while and we don't have much time left".

Katsuki just took a deep breath and stared at the ceiling, feeling slightly lightheaded from the emotional outburst. He didn't agree but didn't object, either. Doctor Matsuo took his silent as consent.

"Why do you think he hates you?"

Katsuki stared at her, squinting his eyes.

"What?"

"Midoriya-kun. Why would he hate you?"

"Why would he *not* hate me?", Katsuki scoffed.

"Well, that is the question. You have told me once that you couldn't understand why he *didn't* hate you. Now you seem to be pretty certain that he does. I don't know what has changed between the two of you in this meantime other than your fight, but you have done a lot of bad things to him during your childhood together", she raised an eyebrow at him. "And he never hated you before. So why would he hate you now?"

Katsuki looked away. He couldn't tell, she couldn't know. Of course, for an outsider his fear of Deku hating him because of a stupid fight after everything he had done to him would sound ludicrous, but Katsuki knew the weight of his actions – he had taken Deku's quirk from him, he had made him quirkless again. Doctor Matsuo didn't know that, but he did, and

so did Deku. That alone made the weight of every single shitty thing Katsuki had ever done to him heavier – and no one other than him and Deku could truly understand why. Not even All Might could understand why.

Katsuki sighed.

“I don’t want to talk about it”, he said for what felt like the thousandth time in her room.

There was a pause.

“Is that so?”

He glared at her.

“Yeah”.

“Well, I would like it if you talked about it”.

He gritted his teeth. His glare became more intense. She had never insisted before when he said he didn’t want to talk about a certain subject, and the unexpected intrusion made him defensive.

“Too bad”, he scoffed in annoyance.

“Katsuki”.

He was silent. He didn’t even complain about her calling him his first name – it had started to happen a while back, after his breakdown in her office, and he couldn’t say he was exactly annoyed by it. If anything, it would feel a bit wrong to have her call him “Bakugou-kun” after witnessing him in his rawest state.

“Why do you think you are being avoidant?”, she asked curiously, making Katsuki glare at her again.

“*What*?”

“You haven’t left the house”.

“So what?”

“So, I’d like you to think about the reason behind that”.

“I didn’t feel like going out”.

“Why not?”

Because I didn’t want to risk seeing him

“Because I didn’t want to”.

“And the fact that Midoriya-kun lives near you had no interference in this?”

He huffed out a breath and looked away.

“I am not pointing fingers”, she explained. “Or trying to make you feel bad, or guilty. I’m just trying to make you see that you have been adopting this avoidant behavior in a lot of aspects of your life – not just in therapy. And while it is my job to make sure you feel comfortable and only share what you want me to know, I’m sure you can tell by now that the real world isn’t that kind”.

He lowered his head in anger.

“So no, I am not going to force you to tell me why you think Midoriya-kun hates you if you don’t feel comfortable with that. But you *will* have to leave the house at some point, and you will have to see Kirishima-kun and your other friends eventually, even if only at school. You know you can’t hide away in your house forever, especially because it seems to be an environment that makes you feel even *more* stressed out. So do you think avoidance really is the best strategy?”

“Well, it clearly fucking isn’t, is it?”, Katsuki snapped, and before the therapist even had to say anything, he was already placing a coin inside his swear jar.

“I’m glad you can acknowledge that”, she nodded. “So, would you like to talk about it?”

“Yes”, he admitted, chest tight and teeth gritted. “But I *can’t*”.

Something in his voice must have told Doctor Matsuo that there was something bigger at stake, because she leaned forwards on her chair and gave him a worried glance.

“You *can’t*?”, she frowned. “Or you won’t?”

“I can’t”, Katsuki sighed, shaking his head and feeling like he was on the verge of breaking – into tears or into another fit of anger, he couldn’t tell. It was getting harder to tell the difference, these days, and he had found that anger was a feeling very similar to sorrow – overwhelming, and burning, and frustrating.

He desperately wanted to talk to her, to talk to *anyone*, about how taking Deku’s quirk had ruined everything for him, about how guilty and terrible and miserable he felt, about how he just wanted to give it back to the shitty nerd and get this damn story over with. But he couldn’t. He couldn’t risk All Might’s secret like this, he couldn’t just tell a random person a secret as dangerous as that just because he was feeling blue. He couldn’t risk *Doctor Matsuo’s* safety like that, either. There were bigger things at stake than his touchy-feely emotions, and he needed to suck it up and deal with it and that was *it*.

He wasn’t looking at Doctor Matsuo, but he could tell that she had understood whatever this was about had to be bigger than Katsuki. Despite his initial resistance to therapy, he had managed to reach a point where he didn’t hesitate to spill his thoughts when they upset him, no matter how rude or angry they were. And after his breakdown in her office, she could tell their relationship was heading towards a better path. If he said he couldn’t tell her, she decided to believe it.

“Is there anyone you can talk to about it, then?”, she suggested.

Katsuki threw his head back, annoyed.

“Yeah, but he doesn’t want to talk to me”.

A beat.

“Are you sure about that?”

“Yeah”.

“He did send you a text asking to talk. Do you think he would have done that unless he actually wanted to talk to you?”

Katsuki sighed.

“Fine, then. *I* don’t want to talk to him”.

“And why is that?”

He threw his hands up in a gesture of anger and annoyance, fed up with his therapist’s insistence. He was having a hard time controlling his growing anger.

“Because I don’t want to”.

“You don’t want to, or you feel like you shouldn’t want to?”

Katsuki finally met her eyes again. She was serious.

“What the hell is that supposed to mean?”

“It means that you’re allowed to feel things, Katsuki”, she explained patiently. “Other than anger, I mean. And that there’s nothing wrong with having feelings for Midoriya-kun, or with missing his company. You two did spend a whole month together”.

Katsuki scoffed.

“I don’t have *feelings* for him”.

“Having feelings for someone isn’t exclusively romantic”.

He scrunched his nose up.

“Who the hell said anything about *romantic*?!”

“No one. That is exactly my point. You’re allowed to like him, or to worry about him, or to care for him, however you want. It doesn’t make you weak, or vulnerable. If anything, it’s just evidence of how much you’ve grown as a person”.

Katsuki glared at her, pensive. He shook his head slightly.

“It *does* make me weak”.

She raised her eyebrows.

“What do –“

“I made myself deaf”, he cut her off before she could ask the question. “Because the guy – the villain – was hurting him. He separated us, and he stole Deku’s soul, so I didn’t think. I just acted on impulse. And I *never* act on impulse”.

Doctor Matsuo studied him.

“And look at where I am, now”, he scoffed. “Can’t hear out of one ear, and Deku can’t even stand the sight of me anymore. So yeah. Having – *feelings* for him isn’t good for anyone – not for me, not for him. And I’m not talking about just – caring about him, or whatever. I’m talking about hating him, too”.

A beat.

“If I hadn’t hated him – if I hadn’t spent so much time feeling angry at him…”, he shook his head. “None of this would have happened”.

Silence.

“So you are saying you think both your lives would have been better if you hadn’t met each other?”

Katsuki scoffed.

“Yeah”.

“But then, you wouldn’t be here”, Doctor Matsuo said without missing a beat.

Katsuki frowned.

“What?”

“If you and Midoriya-kun didn’t know each other, you might have been killed by the sludge villain”.

Katsuki stared at her.

“Nah… The idiot would have jumped in to save me even if he *didn’t* know me”.

“Are you sure?”

“Yeah. He has no instincts of self-preservation. Or brains, for that matter”.

“Why didn’t he do it, then?”

“*Hah?*”

“You have told me this story before. And, from what you said, he only tried to help after he saw it was *you* being attacked. Not before. You told me he only ran in after you two made eye contact”.

Silence.

“He only helped because he knew you. And because he knew it was *you*”.

Katsuki huffed out an annoyed breath, looking away in irritation.

“Fine, so I’d be seven feet under. Doesn’t change my point”.

She raised her eyebrows in surprise.

“Why is that?”

“Because I still gave him a shitty childhood. It would still have been better if we hadn’t ever been friends or enemies in the first damn place. He’d still try to help with the sludge villain shit if we were only acquaintances from school”.

“Are you sure?”

He glared at her.

“I’m not gonna go over all the times I fucked him up. All the times I was a brat and said mean shit and hurt him. I already told you about that. And I already told you about Deku’s shitty self-preservation skills”.

“Yes”, she nodded. “You also already told me about how Midoriya-kun himself said your behavior motivated him to push himself harder. And, because of this, he is now at the school of his dreams, being trained by his childhood hero, and he is no longer friendless or unhappy”.

“Yeah, and he also almost died because of me”.

Doctor Matsuo stared at him.

“Do you think he regrets that decision?”

“Are you *endorsing* shitty Deku’s reckless behavior? Or the fucking bullying I did to him?”, he squinted at her.

“Midoriya-kun isn’t my patient. You are”, she clarified. “My job is to help *you*, not him. The only actions you are responsible for are –“

“*My own*. You keep telling me that”, Katsuki interrupted. A tense pause. “But it’s not true”, he concluded.

“How so?”

“If I hadn’t done everything I did, Deku wouldn’t be where he is right now. My actions influenced his actions”.

“And what do you make of that?”

Katsuki laughed a humorless laugh.

“I make that I’m fucking responsible for all the shit that went down with him. From day one, yeah, but also for – this. The coma and the shit that followed”, Katsuki scoffed.

“But didn’t Midoriya-kun choose to do that on his own? Take the blow for you, I mean?”

“Yeah, *after* I influenced him. He grew up with a fucked-up idea of what a hero is supposed to be”.

To me, you're nothing less than the very incarnation of victory!

“What do you mean?”

He scoffed.

“If I hadn’t pushed him so hard – if I hadn’t forced him to adapt and demand more from himself and try his fucking hardest – he wouldn’t be here”.

“Yes”.

“And he wouldn’t have almost died. Because he would have settled for mediocrity. And he would be fucking *safer* that way”.

Doctor Matsuo tilted her head to the side.

“So you regret what you did not because you think it was wrong, but because your actions brought Midoriya-kun to UA?”

“No”, Katsuki sighed. “Well, *yes*. I know what I did to him was fucked up, I’m not an idiot. I know I was too much of an asshole, and I did and said things that I shouldn’t have, looking back to it. And I’m not sure I like that part of myself anymore, that part that enjoyed hurting him, or that despised him, or that hated him. But I also know that’s what put Deku where he is today. I was the one who made him… this”.

“Katsuki”.

“*What*”.

“I hate to break this to you, but you’re not the center of the universe”.

He scoffed.

“Yeah. I’ve heard that a lot”.

“I mean it”.

He glared at her, curious.

“Yes, you are talented, and yes, you have a lot of potential”, she nodded “but that doesn’t mean you have that sort of power over people. If Midoriya-kun chose to take the blow for you, or to fight the sludge villain to save you, or to leave you at the dorm after you fought, those were *his* choices. You weren’t his only influence growing up – you have told me he also admired All Might a lot. You can’t know for sure if his determination to become a hero would have been undermined, had you not bullied him. In fact, from what you’ve told me about him, I would dare to say his determination would have been even *fiercer* had that been the case. If he chose to stick around you as you grew up, even after you bullied him and mistreated him, he did that out of his own free will. And of course your actions, and what you say and do to people, have an effect. Because that’s what people are: a collection of interactions and experiences that mold and shape who you become. You *always* need to be careful how you treat someone, because words and actions will *always* have an effect. But that doesn’t mean people are just one thing forever, or that people can’t change for the best, even if they have terrible experiences or inflict terrible experiences on others”.

Katsuki kept glaring at her, and he sniffed.

“Our goal in this world isn’t to find happiness, but try our hardest to be the best possible version of ourselves”, she continued. “At the end of the day, you and Midoriya-kun chose to do those things you did, positive and negative, and his choices were not your choices, despite what you did to him in the past. Right now, after everything you went through, you are *choosing* to be a person who is better than the bully you used to be. Do you understand that?”

Katsuki took a deep breath.

“Yes, but –“

“This doesn’t exempt you from what you did to him in the past”, she cut him off, serious. “It doesn’t take the responsibility from you. But the fact that you know those things were wrong and that you feel bad for having done them proves that you have matured and grown a lot over the past months. Because I’m sure you don’t actually wish you had never met Midoriya-kun, if not for the fact that you care about him now, then because you know you could be dead if you hadn’t. What you *wish* is that you hadn’t done those things to him in the past”.

Katsuki looked at her.

“What I’m trying to say, and I’m not sure I’m making myself clear”, she shifted on her seat again, “is that everything that you have done to Midoriya-kun has already happened. None of it can be changed, and you know that – you have said so yourself in several occasions. I also know you know that dwelling on ‘what if’s and ‘what could have been’s doesn’t help anyone, especially not you, which means this is your attempt to hide the *real* reason why you don’t want to talk to Midoriya-kun. So, Katsuki”, she tilted her head. “I would like you to take a moment to think, and then tell me *why* you don’t want to talk to him, even though he told you he was willing to talk to you. I want you to think about why you tried to hide the real reason behind something we both know is not true”.

Katsuki lowered his head, shaking it. Fuck Doctor Matsuo for reading him so well. Was there anything he could hide anymore? Should he even bother? She had already stripped his soul bare.

He bit his lower lip, furious, not meeting her eyes.

“I’m scared”, he admitted, hating how small his voice sounded. Hating how that sentence sounded in his voice. Hating having made the choice to say that aloud in the first place. He felt vulnerable and exposed, pathetic, disgusting.

Doctor Matsuo didn’t say anything, waiting for him to continue.

“I’m *fucking scared*, ok?!”, he barked through gritted teeth, masking those feelings with anger, and hating his voice, and his words, and himself. “And I hate feeling like this, feeling this *weak*, and it’s fucking stupid that I feel this because of shitty *Deku* of all people. He should – He should be the weak one, not me. I’m not supposed to be *weak.* But he’s been around for so fucking long, and everything is fucking changing, my hearing is messed up, my folks are fucked up at work, I keep having these fucking fits and these fucking nightmares all the time, and I don’t feel the same”, he growled, furious. “I’m not the fucking *same*. And everything’s changing, and I used to make do well with just anger all the time, but I can’t go back to that, because Deku’s shitty feelings screwed *my* feelings over, and now I keep feeling all this stuff and it makes me fucking sick and Deku – Deku is the only fucking constant I fucking know. He’s always been there. And I never even realized this shit until I – until I lost him. And he flatlined, and he died for a moment, and I almost lost him for good and it took *that* shit for me to realize that I – as much as I’ve always hated him, I don’t want him to die, I – I don’t – I don’t –“

“You don’t want to lose him”, Doctor Matsuo supplied.

Katsuki bit his lower lip and looked away, neither confirming nor denying it. He took a deep, shaky breath and continued his rant.

“And it’s fucking ridiculous and pathetic and I wish I’d never known the piece of shit, because I hate feeling like this, and I hate that *he* of all people affects me so much, and I hate that *he’s* the one who could feel all my emotions and share them and – and I hate that I’ve grown so used to him that the thought of losing him makes me like – this”, he gestured at himself.

Doctor Matsuo studied him.

“And why does talking to him present a risk of losing him?”

“Because I don’t fucking know what he wants to *tell me*!”, Katsuki shouted, angry, running a hand across his hair. “For all I fucking know he might say that he never wants to see me again and that he hates me, and I know I shouldn’t fucking *care* about that, that’s his fucking problem, but for some fucked up reason I do. I honest to god don’t have a clue why, but now I care, and I wish I didn’t, but I *do*”.

Doctor Matsuo was silent for a beat.

“*Or* he could tell that he’s sorry for walking out on you and that he’s willing to make peace. Don’t you think?”, she suggested.

Katsuki scoffed, a humorless smile blossoming on his lips as he rolled his eyes in scorn. She didn’t get it. She’d never get it, because she didn’t know about the quirk, she didn’t know that Katsuki had stripped Deku from the *one* thing he had spent a lifetime bullying him for not having. She couldn’t understand how fucked up that was.

“Yeah, *or* it could be the first fucking option”, he said bitterly. “So it’s better if I never find out”.

“Katsuki”.

“What?!”

She stared at him.

“Like I’ve told you before”, she said patiently. “You can’t run forever”.

“Yeah. And listening to your fucking advice was what caused the fight in the first place”.

Doctor Matsuo frowned, genuinely confused.

“What?”

“I decided not to ‘run away’ anymore, to face my problem face first, so I fucking talked to him and now Deku hates me”.

She tilted her head to the side.

“Allegedly”.

“*Decisively*”, he barked back. “There’s no way he’ll ever forgive me”.

“He’s forgiven you for worse things than a fight. You saved his life from the villain –“

“No!”, he interrupted. “It’s fucking different, and you wouldn’t understand, so don’t even fucking bother!”

She stared at him. He was on his feet, fuming, angry, face red and teeth bare. He didn’t remember getting up.

Doctor Matsuo looked calm and collected. She quietly removed her glasses before continuing.

“Do you think you do not deserve forgiveness?”

Katsuki deflated, tired.

“You have stated more than once that you don’t understand why Midoriya-kun doesn’t hate you. Now that he allegedly does, you don’t seem to want him to stop. In fact, you seem to be

putting a special effort to keep things that way".

He stared at her, panting and swallowing dry.

"He reached out for you, and you turned away from him".

Deku, reaching a tiny hand out for him, and his own hand, slapping Deku's outstretched one away in disgust and anger and outrage –

"Almost like you're trying to punish yourself. By isolating yourself from him, and from your friends, and by picking up fights with your mother. So why do you feel like you need to be punished?"

He scoffed.

"I don't –"

"Katsuki. We're way past this", she told him seriously.

Katsuki sighed, sitting back down.

"I *don't* feel like I need to be punished", he argued. "I know what I did in the past was shitty, but like you said, he's forgiven me for it. He told me so. I just –", he clicked his tongue. "I – don't want him to hate me. So if he does, it's better if I don't know".

"Why don't you want him to hate you?"

He sighed heavily and groaned, throwing his head back in frustration. Why did she always ask so many questions?!

"We've *been there already*", he spat angrily. "Everything in my life is fucking changing and he's the only constant I have left".

"But him hating you doesn't change that", Doctor Matsuo provided. "Do you really think he will drop out of the school of his dreams if he hates you?"

Katsuki glared at her.

"He will still be around, and you two have had a distant relationship ever since you were kids. Up until recently, he's only ever been a background presence in your life, and in case he *really* does hate you now, that's what he'll go back to being. So I don't think the issue here is whether or not Midoriya-kun is a constant for you. The issue is why the possibility that he hates you bothers you so much".

Katsuki sighed in annoyance, leg bouncing anxiously.

"Fine, it's not the possibility he hates me".

"Then what is it?"

Katsuki gritted his teeth.

“It’s the possibility he doesn’t”.

Doctor Matsuo was silent.

“I don’t follow”.

“Of course you don’t”.

“Care to elaborate?”

“It’s complicated”.

“I’m willing to make an effort to understand”.

He sighed, throwing his head back.

“It’s not about loving me or hating me. It’s about… neither”.

She was silent for a moment.

“So you fear his indifference?”

“I don’t *fear* it”.

“Fine. But it makes you uncomfortable”.

Katsuki glared at the wall beside him. He nodded silently.

“Why is that?”

He closed his eyes for a brief moment.

Kacchan, sugoi!

You are the person Midoriya shonen holds the most admiration, love, devotion, and reverence for

You really are the hero he always knew you would become

I care about you! I always did and I always will, no matter how many times you step on me or put me down! To me, you're nothing less than the very incarnation of victory!

Katsuki sniffed, face scrunching up in anger and frustration.

“I don’t know”, he admitted, voice breaking.

“You don’t?”, she asked, as if she thought Katsuki was trying to hide the answer from her. But he wasn’t. He really didn’t know.

“I don’t”, he repeated, shaking his head.

She sighed, patient.

“All right. Then tell me this: do *you* hate him?”

He shook his head.

“Not anymore”.

“And is he indifferent in your life?”

“Tch”, he huffed, shaking his head no. He hated to admit it, but it was the truth. It was pointless to keep pretending he didn’t give a shit about Deku.

“And how do you feel about him?”

“I –“, he hesitated.

That was quite possibly the toughest fucking question she could have asked him at that point of his life. Because things between Deku and him had changed. They had changed so fucking much, and he couldn’t keep saying Deku was *just* his rival, or *just* his friend. He couldn’t keep saying he was both, either. He couldn’t figure out, for the life of him, why Deku – and his presence, and his admiration – seemed to mean so much to him now, when he never really thought or cared about that before. Was that a classic case of not realizing how important something is until you lose it? Because what he felt now was more than fondness, and it felt wrong, because this was Deku – he shouldn’t have incited fondness into Katsuki *in the first place*, let alone something stronger. And yet… here he was.

“I care about him”, he admitted, even though that was old news (for Doctor Matsuo at least).

Because honestly, how could he *not* care about Deku after everything they lived through in the past months? After watching Deku fucking die and taking his quirk to save his life? After losing his hearing for him? After *Deku* laid down his life for Katsuki’s with no hesitation?

“I don’t want to see him getting hurt again, after all the shit he already went through because of me”, he continued, taken by a sudden surge of courage. “And – I used to think that he looked down on me, that he thought he was better than me, but now that I know he doesn’t, I think – I think that helped me tolerate him more, even though I still see him as my competition”.

“Yes”, Doctor Matsuo nodded as if she already knew all that. “But do you long for him?”

Katsuki stared at her in shock.

“…What?”

“Do you long for his company, and his praise, and his admiration, and his devotion? Is that what you fear losing?”

Katsuki looked away.

“Yes”, he admitted silently.

“And why is that?”

The only sound in the room was the constant tic-tac from the clock at the wall. Katsuki couldn’t bring himself to look at his therapist, or to meet her eyes, or to move from his seat. He didn’t know the answer, even if it was at the tip of his tongue. He just didn’t know.

An eternity passed in unbreakable silence.

“Our time is up”, Doctor Matsuo announced after years, when it became clear Katsuki was not speaking up. “It’s been for a while now. But I wanted to tell you something before you go, since it will be a month until we see each other again”.

He nodded, not meeting her gaze.

“No one is irredeemable, Katsuki. People make mistakes, some worse than others, but it doesn’t mean you have to spend the rest of your life paying for them. If Midoriya-kun has forgiven you, then you are forgiven. And since this is our last session for this semester, I’m allowed to tell you that your progress has been very good. You are getting increasingly better at controlling your outbursts, even if you still have them sometimes, and you are becoming more aware of what triggers them. That’s a good development. But there’s still one thing you have to learn before I can clear you for good”.

He met her eyes.

“You are more than just your anger”, she told him seriously. “And you are more than just a future pro-hero, like you described yourself in our first session. Your anger does not define who you are. Your other feelings have always been in there, even if you didn’t realize it before, and there is no shame in *feeling* them. Exposing them. Allowing yourself to experience them. And there’s no shame in feeling anger, either – you just need to know how to control it so that you don’t hurt others, or yourself, and so that it doesn’t get out of hand. *Any* type of excess is harmful: it’s balance you should aim for. And when you learn how to fully balance your feelings – when you learn to acknowledge them better – I think *then*, yes, you’re going to be one of the best pro-heroes Japan has ever seen”.

Katsuki lowered his eyes, trying to hide how moist they were becoming. He had heard that sentence – that praise – many times across his life, but this was the first occasion in which it felt completely sincere. This woman knew all his flaws, all his insecurities, all his mistakes, and she still believed in him. Somehow, that was more meaningful than any of the other times he had heard about how he would make a great hero.

“But don’t let it go to your head, young mister”, Doctor Matsuo added with a smile to diffuse the tension, having the decency to pretend she hadn’t realized how emotional Katsuki looked. “You still have a long way ahead of you”.

Katsuki scoffed out a half-humorous smile, sniffing and looking away.

“You’re good to go, now”, she announced, and he immediately got to his feet, not looking at her as he headed to the door. “Try to put some thought into what I asked you, during your break. And hey”, she called after him before he could get halfway there. “Take the jar with you”.

He met her eyes, inquiry written over crimson.

“It’s nearly Christmas, after all”, she shrugged. “Consider this the first step for a peace offering”.

“Why?”, he frowned. “We didn’t have a fight or anything, you’re just doing your job”.

“I didn’t say the peace offering was for me”, she offered him a tiny smile and a raise of eyebrows. “And, like I said, it’s nearly Christmas”.

Katsuki swallowed dry. He crossed the small room and grabbed the swear jar with one hand, staring at it.

“I said a lot of swearwords I didn’t pay for today”, he admitted, pensive.

“Yes”, she nodded. “But, just today, I feel like you could use a break. Don’t get used to it, though”.

Katsuki stared at her, the tiny hint of a smile appearing at the corner of his lips.

“What? I told you that real world isn’t kind; it doesn’t mean it can’t have kind people in it. Plus, you were always going to get the jar back anyway. It’s a bit illegal for me to hoard money from my patients”.

Katsuki snorted out a teasing smirk.

“Isn’t that your job description?”

“Watch it”, Doctor Matsuo told him, standing up from her chair and leading him to the door, even though the smile was still painting her lips. Katsuki sighed, put the jar full of coins in his backpack, and allowed the therapist to see him out.

“Hey”, she called after him as he stood beside her without meeting her eyes, waiting for her to open the door.

He looked up at her, her hand resting against the door handle.

“Text me if you need anything during our break, ok?”, she told him seriously.

Katsuki averted his eyes from her. Nodded briefly.

“Have a nice vacation”, he told her without looking at her as he stepped out of her office, the words coming naturally off his lips.

“And you”, she replied with a proud smile before he left.

Inko looked shocked when she opened her front door and saw Katsuki standing there.

Correction: Inko looked shocked when she opened her front door and saw Katsuki standing there, carrying a bag of two wrapped presents, of all things.

It had been a few days since his last session with Doctor Matsuo, but their conversation kept echoing at the back of his head, especially with all the free time Katsuki had in hands now. And while the decision to come over and finally face Deku once and for all had been his and his only, he couldn't deny that his long and emotional session with the therapist had played an important role in that. It had also played an important role in making him lose hours of sleep thinking about what the hell all her questions meant and what the hell were the answers to them, which got him dangerously close to talking to Kirishima about it.

(He didn't. But he at least answered the last one of his friend's texts, which was an improvement compared to the week-long ghosting Katsuki had given him).

"K-Katsuki-kun", Inko said, green eyes wide. "W-What… You…?"

"Yeah", he cut her off simply, knowing exactly what she must have thought. "It's Christmas tomorrow", he shrugged, subtly gesturing at the bag of presents and hoping that would be enough to make Inko understand.

Even if the snow had gotten a bit better ever since that atypical, fatidic day at the dorm, it was still cold as hell out in the streets. Katsuki was wearing a winter coat, a scarf, and a beanie, but he was still trembling slightly – he wasn't a great fan of cold weather. Inko must have realized this, because she stepped aside to clear him passage, and so Katsuki stepped into the Midoriya's home, feeling like he was returning to a familiar place and entering a dangerous territory at the same time.

In a similar manner to the other times in which he visited, Katsuki stood awkwardly at the center of the living room as Inko closed the door behind him and approached him. She stood before him with sad eyes, but there was a sympathetic, almost relieved smile threatening to blossom at her lips as she reached forwards to grab his bag and his coat. Katsuki gave them to her in silence, an unreadable expression on his face.

"I'm afraid my Izuku isn't here right now", she announced as she placed Katsuki's coat on the coat-hanger and deposited his bag carefully on the couch. "But he should be back anytime, now. He and All Might went out for lunch".

Oh, right. All Might. Katsuki had almost completely forgotten about the guy after the last time they saw each other, since the former number one had told him he could follow the training routine he had learned on his own during the school break. He probably just wanted to ditch Katsuki in order to spend as much time as possible with Deku, which could be proved by the fact they had both gone out for lunch on Christmas eve. And, much to Katsuki's own surprise, the thought didn't bother him – it didn't even cause him envy or contempt. He had come to terms with the fact that Deku was All Might's chosen one, not him.

Not him.

Which is why he shouldn't have this *shitty fucking quirk* in the first place.

(Ok. Ok, Katsuki, deep breaths. Get a fucking hold of yourself.)

"Should he be out in this cold?", Katsuki found himself asking out of an attempt to fill in the silence and make small talk with Inko, but as soon as the words left his mouth, he hated them – especially because of the way it made Inko look at him. Green eyes all full of sympathy, and something akin to pity, too.

Katsuki's gut response was to be rude to her only to wipe that pity from her eyes, because pity was something he hated giving and receiving, but he simply looked away instead as he sat down on the couch uninvited.

"He will be fine", Inko reassured him, sitting beside him without taking offense. "I made sure he was warm and All Might is keeping an eye on him. They shouldn't be long, now".

"Hm", was Katsuki's response.

An uncomfortable silence ensued.

"So…", Inko said after a few moments. "How have you been?"

Katsuki stared at her, frowning as if she had grown a second head.

"Fine", he answered shortly. Inko tilted her head to the side.

"You look thinner than when I last saw you. Did you have lunch yet?"

"Yeah", Katsuki said. "Before I came here".

"Oh".

More silence. Katsuki sighed.

"Look", he said, standing up from the couch. "I just stopped by to give you and Deku these", he pointed at the bag, which was still sitting at the couch. "It's not a big deal or anything. You can tell him I came here when he arrives".

And, saying this, he headed to the door.

“Wait!”, Inko got to her feet and trailed after him. “What do you mean, Izuku and I? Why are you in such a rush?”

Katsuki turned to face her.

“I won’t sit around here waiting for Deku to come back all day. I’ve got stuff to do”.

“On Christmas eve?”, Inko questioned, not buying the excuse. Katsuki narrowed his eyes.

“Yes”, he responded shortly, in a way that was supposed to be menacing.

“Katsuki-kun”, Inko sighed, taking one of his hands and squeezing it. He stared down at her.

“What?”

Inko sighed.

“It’s past the time you two solve this. I don’t know what happened –“

“Look –“

“*No*”, Inko interrupted him, firm. “I don’t know what happened between you two, Izuku wouldn’t tell me. But I *do* know enough is enough. Whatever it is, you need to solve this, the two of you. I think we have all been through too much for you to keep fighting like two little kids”.

Katsuki stared at her in silence, face serious.

“I almost lost my son. The past months have been horrible, and he’s only now getting back to what he used to be. I just want to see my boy happy”, she said.

Katsuki sighed and faced away from her, his hand still held by hers.

“So, please, whatever this is –“

“He’s the one who stopped talking to me. Not the other way around”.

Inko paused.

“What?”

“Yeah”, Katsuki met her eyes again. “I only kept my distance because I thought that was what he wanted”.

Inko looked shocked again as she frowned up at Katsuki.

“But he sent me a text saying he was ready to talk”, Katsuki shrugged as he looked away again. “So that’s why I came over”.

Inko didn’t waste time.

“Then stay”, she squeezed his hand, leading him back towards the couch in an almost urgent manner. “Like I said, he should be back any minute now”.

Katsuki sighed, stopping on his tracks as Inko pulled him.

“Look, I –“, he looked away. “I should probably just go”.

He stared at the queue of kid pictures framing the furniture of the house, at the kids’ drawing hanging from the wall, at everything around him that screamed *Deku* at him. Katsuki had thought he had been ready for this, but he wasn’t. This was too much. Inko’s kindness was too much. She should hate him. She should kick him out.

But Deku had forgiven him, and so had her. Katsuki hadn’t forced her to do it. She had chosen it. And maybe… Fuck, no. No *maybes*. It was past the time he gathered his courage and ended this shitty story, once and for all.

“Ok”, Inko nodded at him, looking conflicted as she let go of him. “Ok, all right. I won’t stop you, if that is what you really want. But just know that – w-well. I would like it if you stayed. At least until I open my present?”, she suggested.

Katsuki glared at her, then at the bag. Then at her again. He hated the way her eyes looked.

He rolled his eyes, sighed, and nodded.

“Good!”, she smiled, looking genuinely happy, and the picture made Katsuki feel repulse and warmth at the same time. He sat back at the couch as Inko rushed to the kitchen and grabbed them a tray with cookies and warm tea. “I just got it done”, she explained as she set a cup in front of Katsuki at the coffee table. He picked it up and took a sip in silence, nodding his gratitude at her.

“Yours is the bigger one”, he nodded at the bag with the two wrapped gifts. Inko blushed slightly but grabbed the bag anyway, pulling the biggest box out.

“You didn’t have to buy me anything, Katsuki-kun”, she reprimanded lightly, but her voice was shy. “I – well, I mean, how rude of me, I didn’t even get you anything…”

“You didn’t have to”, Katsuki shrugged, his face looking slightly grumpy. He looked away as Inko unwrapped her gift, but met her eyes as she gasped in surprise.

“Oh!”, she exclaimed, lifting the box with the pottery set Katsuki had gotten her. “Oh, no, I can’t accept this, it must have been so expensive –“, she shook her head, her face horrified and red.

“It wasn’t”, Katsuki interrupted her with a huff. “The lady at the store said this set keeps food warmer for longer, so I thought you could use it. And the one in the middle is good for serving katsudon”.

Inko stared up at Katsuki with tears in her expressive eyes.

“Katsuki-kun…”, she whispered, sounding emotional. Katsuki suppressed the urge to roll his eyes again at the display.

“It’s not a big deal”, he assured her, sounding a bit defensive. “And you don’t have to get me anything in return. It’s the least I could do”.

Inko set the box aside and surged forwards to hug him, which hey, he should totally have expected since this was *Inko Midoriya*, hugger extraordinaire, but he hadn’t been hugged in so long that he had almost forgotten what it felt like, and he had definitely forgotten what *Inko’s* hugs felt like, because they always made him feel like he could just forget his problems for a little while and let her take the weight from his shoulders, if only for a few seconds. He rested his chin on her shoulder and didn’t hug her back, as it seemed to be their usual protocol whenever they hugged. Inko wasn’t bothered by it, and rubbed a soothing hand across Katsuki’s back as he allowed himself to be held by her. It felt nice.

Katsuki hated the fact that he had missed this.

When she broke the hug, she wiped her own tears away with her thumbs, offering him a warm smile. He squeezed one of his shoulders and rubbed it soothingly.

“Thank you”, she told him sincerely. “It was a very nice Christmas gift”.

Katsuki nodded at her. She smiled.

“You should probably come over sometime, before school starts again. We can try to test out the new –“

“Mom, I’m home!”, a too-familiar voice announced from the front door, sounding lively and excited and happy in a way Katsuki hadn’t heard in a long time, and he immediately felt his blood run cold. “You won’t believe what happened to All Might at the food court of the –”.

Silence.

“Izuku!”, Inko cheered, getting to her feet. Katsuki stayed exactly where he was, still as a statue, not turning his head to look at the door or even moving an inch on his seat. He had no idea what Deku’s face looked like, finding him sitting there at his living room. Was he disappointed? Relieved? Happy? Furious? Katsuki had all the means to turn and find out, but he stayed where he was.

“Uh… Hey, mom”, he said, voice completely different from when he first arrived. “H-Hey, Kacchan”.

Only then did Katsuki turn to look at the boy, his body responding more automatically to the call of his name than out of his will.

Deku was looking a bit better than Katsuki had last seen him, his cheeks the tiniest bit chubbier – he probably had Inko’s cooking to thank for that – and with a healthier pink to them. His eyes didn’t look as sunken, even if there were still purple bags beneath them, and his growing hair still stood out against the remaining boniness of his skull. Though he was

undeniably healthier, he was still too thin – Katsuki could see the way his hoodie and his pants hung loosely from his skeletal form. How Deku had managed to go out during winter without shaking like a leaf was beyond him.

It was the look in his eyes, however, that bothered Katsuki the most – it wasn't happy, but it wasn't angry, either. it wasn't sad, and it wasn't scared, and it wasn't annoyed – he had no idea what that look meant. At least it wasn't indifferent, and Katsuki found himself getting to his feet, a sudden surge of determination overcoming him.

"I…", Inko said, clearly awkward with all the tension between her son and his… Well. What were they, exactly? Rivals? Former best friends? Enemies? Katsuki had no idea. *Her son and his Kacchan.* "I will give you boys some privacy to talk…"

"No, mom", Izuku interrupted her, his eyes never leaving Katsuki's, as if he feared the boy would disappear should he look away. His tone wasn't rude or sharp, but reassuring. All Katsuki did was stand there and stare back. "It's ok. We'll talk in my room".

Katsuki narrowed his eyes at Deku, but didn't say anything. Inko hesitated, awkwardly holding the tray with the teacups. Eventually, she nodded.

"All right, dear. Call me if you need anything, ok?", she smiled at Izuku. Izuku finally took his eyes away from Katsuki and smiled back at his mom, the gesture small and shy but still enough to make a tiny set of dimples appear at either side of his cheeks. Katsuki tightened one of his hands into a fist.

Izuku met his eyes again, nodding at the direction of his room before turning on his heels and walking away without a word. Katsuki would have found the gesture revolting, in the past – how dare stupid Deku think he can order him around like that? – but now, he simply followed him in silence.

"Oh, Katsuki-kun!", Inko called after him, making both boys stop on his tracks and turn to look at her. "Don't forget the bag", she nodded at the bag which was sitting at the couch, Izuku's present still inside. Katsuki could feel the blood rising to his cheeks as he walked back to the couch with a grumpy face and basically snatched it into his hands.

Izuku spared him a quick glance that would have been unnoticeable had Katsuki not been paying such close attention to him, and opened the door to his room, stepping inside. As Katsuki followed him in, Izuku began to remove his winter coat, leaving him only in a navy-blue hoodie and his jeans. When he removed his shoes, revealing a pair of All Might-themed socks, Katsuki clicked the door of the room shut behind him and stood in front of frame, uncertain of what to do with himself.

He knew why Deku had called him into his room to talk. They couldn't risk Inko overhearing their conversation.

He also knew he should have expected the ridiculous amount of All Might merch he knew he would find in there, but he was still taken aback by it. He looked around to find posters and posters and posters of All Might, all from different eras, as well as toys and figurines and plushes and a bed-set that was probably purchased from a kid's store. The whole bedroom

was All Might, but at the same time it was so *Deku* that Katsuki couldn't help but to feel like he knew it by heart, even though he hadn't been inside it in almost a decade. In fact, he couldn't remember what was the last time he was over at Deku's before the soul incident.

What was the last time he decided Deku's place was worth coming over to.

A movement from the corner of his eyes drew his attention and Katsuki turned his head just to see Deku moving his hands at him. Using sign language, his brain took a millisecond to decipher. And then, it made sense – even if they were inside Deku's bedroom, there was still a risk that Inko would walk by and overhear something about One For All, and they couldn't have that. Luckily for them, they had both found a way to communicate with each other without the risk of being over*heard*.

"*What's in the bag?*", Deku signed, a curious yet reserved expression on his face. Katsuki looked down at the bag, which was still in his hands, before crossing the distance between them in the room and handing it over to Deku, who was sitting at the edge of his bed. Behind him, Katsuki could see the All Might plush he had given him back at the hospital, when he found out Deku was sleeping with a fucking keychain beneath his pillow.

He didn't know how to feel about that. The exchange felt like it had happened a lifetime ago, when things were nice between them for the first time in forever.

"*It's Christmas tomorrow*", he signed back at the nerd as he took a few steps back. Deku peeked inside the bag and pulled out the wrapped gift from inside, until he looked up to see Katsuki's awkwardly standing form in the middle of his room.

"*You can take a seat*", Izuku signed at him, and Katsuki's instant reaction was to shout at him that he didn't need his fucking permission to do any fucking thing, but instead he simply grabbed a hold of Deku's rolling chair, which was sitting in front of his studying desk, and pushed it closer to the bed – not too close, but far enough. Once he was sitting down, Izuku resumed opening his present.

He finished tearing through the wrapping paper to reveal a dusty-looking, slightly crumpled Golden Era All Might figurine. Izuku frowned, looking up at him with wide eyes.

After days of pondering, Katsuki had reached the conclusion that giving Deku a personal, close-to-home present would be better than buying him something brand-new. He'd always been emotional about nostalgic shit like that. Plus, Katsuki's folks could use the money he had collected in the therapy with Doctor Matsuo.

"*I know you that's the only one you don't have*", Katsuki shrugged as he signed, trying to assume a nonchalant stance. Izuku blinked at him before setting the box aside and rising his shaky hands to sign:

"*How did you know?*"

"*I won it in a special contest, five years ago. It was limited edition, only ten people in the whole world have it*".

Izuku swallowed dry, staring down at his lap before taking a deep breath.

"*I can't take it*".

"*Your mom said the same thing when I gave her her present*".

Izuku frowned harder.

"*You gave my mom a present?*"

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

"*Like I said, it's Christmas tomorrow*".

Izuku stared at him for a long while, and Katsuki sustained his gaze.

"*Why didn't you tell me before?*"

Katsuki didn't have to ask what he was talking about.

"*I mean*", Izuku continued to sign before Katsuki could elaborate an answer. "*I get why you didn't want to tell me, and I get why you did what you did. I spoke to All Might, and he explained everything to me. Well, he did his best anyway. But what I don't get is…*", he hesitated. "*Why you took so long to tell me. And why you chose to do it that night. When we were finally…*", he shrugged, shaking his head. "*I don't know. Getting along*".

Katsuki stared at him. A long silence ensued.

"*Kacchan*", Izuku concluded, "*why are you here?*"

Katsuki sighed.

"*You said you were ready to talk".*

"Yes. Over a week ago".

"So you don't want to talk now?"

"I want to know why you didn't even reply to my text. Why you showed up at my house today, after ghosting me for over a week".

"It's Christmas eve".

"Yes, I know that, you've said that a lot. Does Christmas hold a special meaning to us that I'm not aware of?"

Katsuki narrowed his eyes. Izuku's face suddenly fell.

"*Is this… something from the time I spent with you as a ghost?"*

Katsuki scoffed, rubbing a tired hand over his face as he shook his head.

"*No. I just felt like it would be a nice time to attempt a reconciliation. What's so wrong with it?"*

Izuku bit his lower lip, looking almost offended.

"*I'm just",* he signed, before stopping himself. He lowered his head and shook it, before meeting Katsuki's eyes again. "*You make it really hard to understand".*

"What?"

"Everything. I don't think I get you, Kacchan".

Katsuki swallowed dry.

(You don't know shit about me.

Actually, I think I'm finally starting to get you.

You took your fucking time.)

"*I didn't tell you before because I didn't know how you would react, and I didn't want to accidentally give you a heart attack or something. You were too sick. I told you then because I thought you would understand. You were stronger".*

Izuku stared at him.

"*Ok".*

Katsuki frowned.

"*Ok?"*

"Yeah. Ok. I get it".

Katsuki scoffed.

"*Really? You stopped fucking talking to me for two weeks and all you have to say about this shit is 'ok'?"*

Izuku sighed.

"*Do you want me to be mad?"*

"No".

"Then what do you want?"

"I don't know", Katsuki signed angrily. "*Maybe an explanation as to why you've been such a pain in the ass only to drop the subject as if it was nothing".*

“I told you All Might explained everything. He even said you can pass One For All back to me, and I took my time to think about it”.

“So everything’s good now? Just like that?”

“Yes. Unless you want to pick up a fight”.

“Fuck you”, Katsuki gestured angrily. Izuku just stared at him.

“*I don’t understand”.*

“That makes two of us”.

“Do you want me to be angry at you? Is that why you came over?”

“No. I came over to give you your shitty present and sort this crappy situation out. I didn’t come over to have you act like nothing weird happened over the past weeks, like you didn’t act as if what I did was the worst thing ever, or like I didn’t steal your quirk”.

Awkward silence. As soon as Katsuki set his hands down, he knew he had just poured salt into Deku’s wound, if the way his jaw clenched was any indication.

“*You didn’t steal it*”, Izuku gestured patiently. “*Did you?”*

“It was to save your life”, Katsuki signed back, defensive.

“*I know that”.*

“And I don’t want this shit”.

“Yes, I know”.

“And I’ll give it back to you”.

“I know you will”.

“Then why in the goddamn fuck did you do that for, huh?”, Katsuki concluded with rage. He was starting to lose his temper.

“Do what?”

“Leave the dorm like that. Act like I had personally killed your family. Stop talking to me for weeks”.

“Like you had stopped talking to me for weeks before that night at the dorm?”

“Oh, so it was revenge? Is that what the fuck this is about?”

“Of course not”, Izuku frowned, offended. “*I would never do something like that. I just think it’s a bit of hypocrisy to criticize me for something that you did too”.*

"Spare me", Katsuki scoffed. "*If it wasn't for revenge, then why did you do it?"*

"I told you", Izuku signed, serious. "*I needed time to sort my thoughts out. Am I happy that I'm quirkless again? No. Do I think that you, of all people, making me quirkless is a bit messed up? Yes. But do I know that you only did it to save my life and that you'll give it back to me once I'm ok again? Also yes".*

Katsuki glared at him.

"*And it took you* this long *to reach that conclusion? I told you all this shit myself that night!"*

"Yes, and I needed to stop and think about it! It's not like I could be immediately ok with the fact that you made me quirkless again, even if it was to save my life!"

Katsuki continued to glare at him.

"*I was scared, Kacchan. Ok?"*, Izuku continued after a pause, his hands trembling slightly. "*Everyone was clearly keeping secrets from me ever since I woke up. I was weak, and tired, and whenever I looked at myself in the mirror – all I saw was the progress I lost. Everything I worked so hard for, all the effort I made to get where I was, everything was gone, and I was suddenly back to being a weak, bony little boy who couldn't fight to save his life. I felt weird and tired and weak all the time, but I thought it was because of the coma, not because of the quirk. I had spent months in bed and apparently died for a minute, and everyone kept warning me that if I attempted to use One For All before I got better I would probably snap my own spine in half and get myself killed, so I didn't even try it. I didn't even* think *of trying it. What would I use it for in a hospital, anyway? I thought this weakness was my body's fault. My recovery process. And the fact that you were actually being nice to me for once made me realize that I must really have been close to dying, so I wasn't about to risk pushing myself too far".*

Katsuki stared.

"*But then when you told me that you had my quirk, everything started to make sense. Why I felt so weird and empty and* powerless*. So I was scared, ok? That I would be like this forever, that I would feel like this forever, that I would be powerless to save people anymore. That – that I had failed All Might. And I needed to think, I needed to understand what was going on, which is why I didn't talk to you, but once I talked to All Might and he explained everything, I understood. And I don't blame you for doing what you did, and I'm not angry. I might have been back then when you told me, but I'm not now. Not anymore".*

Katsuki scoffed.

"*Why the fuck not?"*

Izuku frowned.

"*What?"*

"Why the fuck aren't you angry? You should be. You have the right to be".

“I know”, Izuku nodded. “*But I’m not”*.

“Why? Are you messed up in the head?”

“No. I just don’t think this is the worst thing you’ve ever done to me”.

Ok, that felt like a slap to his face.

“*Look, Kacchan”,* Izuku sighed. “*I know why you did what you did. And to be honest, I’m grateful. You saved my life. If you hadn’t taken One For All, I would be dead”*.

Katsuki just stared at him.

“*And I know* you. *I’ve known you for years. I know you don’t want my quirk. It would feel like cheating”*.

Katsuki scoffed, the tiniest hint of a smirk appearing at the corner of his mouth.

“*You’re damn right it would. That’s why I’ve never used it”*.

Izuku seemed surprised by that.

“*Really?”*

“What?”

“You never used it?”

“No”.

“Not even by accident?”

“What the hell do you take me for? I know how to control a quirk”.

“I know. It’s just…”, he hesitated.

“*What?”*

“I thought you would have used it. Out of curiosity”.

“I don’t want to use it. It’s not mine, I’m just safekeeping it until you can take it back”.

Izuku stared at him with an unreadable look in his green eyes.

“*You could use it, if you want”*, he shrugged. “*Just to see what it’s like. I don’t mind”*.

“I do”.

“Well…”, he shrugged again. “*All right”*.

“Yeah”.

More silence. Neither of them dared to meet each other's eyes.

"*So we're good?"*, Katsuki signed eventually, his face stern.

"*Yes"*, Izuku responded.

"*Just like that?"*

"Just like that".

Katsuki scoffed, getting up.

"*Ok"*.

"Wait", Izuku signed at him, frowning. "*You're leaving?"*

"Yes".

"I didn't give you your present".

"You don't have to give me one", Katsuki frowned.

"*I already got it",* Izuku signed, getting to his feet and bending over to grab a bag from beside his bed. "Merry Christmas, Kacchan*"*, he said out loud, handing the bag over to Katsuki.

Katsuki glared at Izuku before grabbing the bag from his hands.

"Christmas is tomorrow", he replied out loud as well, just out of spite, pulling the wrapped present from inside and tearing the paper away.

"Don't be difficult", Izuku reprimanded, but Katsuki didn't hear him over the shock of seeing the box in his hands.

It was a Golden Era All Might figurine, *exactly* like the one Katsuki had won five years before and just given to Izuku as a present.

He stared at the boy, who had an apologetic look on his face.

"I know how rare it is", Izuku shrugged, grabbing the very own old box Katsuki had given him. "I never won the contest, but there was a person who did who was selling it online. I thought it would be a nice way to say thank you for saving my life".

Katsuki squinted his eyes.

"No", he shook his head, angry and suspicious. "This must have cost a fortune".

"Kacchan –"

"I said *no*", Katsuki insisted, handing the box over to Izuku a bit too aggressively. "You can keep them both. It's only fair".

“Kacchan!”, Izuku frowned in indignance as Katsuki shoved the second box at him, when he refused to pick it up. “You can’t return a present I gave you!”

“What’s the fucking point of giving you a *rare* All Might figurine if you give me the exact same figurine, you damn nerd?!”, Katsuki protested. “This is my Christmas gift to you – now you’re the *only* person in the world to have two of these”, he nodded at the boxes. “And you’re fucking welcome”.

“This isn’t fair”, Izuku complained. “You ruined my Christmas surprise”.

“*You* ruined my Christmas surprise”, Katsuki accused. “I spent no money and gave you a personal present, while you must have spent half of your mom’s savings to give me something I already have!”

“You *don’t* have it, because you gave it to me!”, Izuku pointed out.

“Yeah, because I never thought your dumbass would be able to find one of these!”

Izuku stared at Katsuki, lips tight, before his entire face broke and he bent forward, heaving, boxes still in his arms.

Katsuki’s eyes widened and he surged forwards, grabbing a hold of Izuku’s shoulder as his heart started to hammer in his chest. What was happening? Was Deku feeling ill? Was he dying? What the fuck –

And then, from the sound Deku was making and the way his shoulders were rattling, sense finally dawned into Katsuki – the fucker was *laughing*.

As soon as he realized this, he let go of the damn nerd, glaring at him for giving him the fright of his life, but Izuku didn’t even see it. He was too busy throwing his head back and laughing loudly, now, as if this was the funniest situation he had ever seen in his entire life. And, despite his anger and his annoyance and the fact that his heart was still racing with adrenaline, Katsuki found himself smiling slightly, and then crookedly, until he was chuckling along with Izuku.

“God”, Izuku wheezed in-between laughs, dropping the boxes of the All Might figurines and hugging his own belly. “W-We’re – we’re both so *stupid*”, he giggled.

“Speak for yourself”, Katsuki replied, but there was no hostility in his voice. “You’re the one who spent a shitload of money”.

“How should I know that you would give me the *exact same thing?* Or that you even *had* it in the first place?!”, Izuku protested in a high-pitched, squealy voice as he tried to keep from laughing so hard.

“I boasted about winning that shitty contest non-stop for almost a month, I thought you’d have remembered it”, *from the way you kept trailing after me all the time*, Katsuki’s brain completed.

The weight of his words seems to affect him harder than it affected Izuku, though, because his smile died down completely at the memory, whereas Izuku's simply dimmed a bit – it was still there, even if more nostalgic than before.

Izuku's laughing fit had been so intense that it resulted on him lying on his side on the bed, green curls splayed around his pinkish face like a halo. Katsuki was sitting beside him, but, after his words totally killed the laughing-gas mood, he allowed himself to fall back and lie beside Izuku, even if uninvited, hands resting above his own belly and legs bending at the edge of the bed so that his feet touched the ground. Izuku's legs were curled up to his belly in a fetal position, and they were both silence for a few moments as Katsuki stared at the ceiling.

"Do you miss it?", Izuku eventually asked.

"Do I miss what?", Katsuki replied, not looking at him.

"I don't know", Izuku shrugged. "The way things were before".

He frowned, turning his head to stare at Izuku as if he had grown a second head. Their faces were really close to each other's on the bed.

"Deku –"

"I don't mean before as in school", Izuku explained before Katsuki could continue. "I definitely don't miss *that*. I'm talking about – *before*", he shrugged. Even though he was lying face-to-face with Katsuki, the tips of their noses almost touching, he was looking away, anywhere but into his crimson eyes. "Before either of us had quirks. Before…", he trailed off, not finishing the thought. He gazed downward.

Katsuki thought for a while, staring at Izuku's face. He could probably count his freckles, if he wanted.

"No", Katsuki responded simply. "I don't miss it".

Izuku met his eyes.

"I prefer it now", Katsuki admitted, feeling uncharacteristically open.

Vulnerable, weak, a voice inside his head provided, sounding suspiciously like his mom.

Izuku stared deep into his eyes for a long while, looking like he wanted to ask something but didn't know how to.

"Y-Yeah", he concluded after a few awkward moments. "I prefer it now, too. Even if we're still getting there".

"Yeah", Katsuki agreed, serious. His eyes were narrowed in a way that made him look angry.

"So… We're going back to texting?", Izuku asked, raising his eyebrows. Katsuki rolled his eyes in an exaggerated way.

“Why you gotta make everything so weird?”

“I’m not! I’m just trying to figure out where we’re standing!”, he defended himself. Katsuki sighed.

“Fine. We can go back to texting”.

Izuku offered him a small smile.

“And you’ll answer this time?”

Katsuki playfully shoved a hand at his shoulder, earning another chuckle from Izuku.

“Shut up. You know why I didn’t answer”.

Izuku’s face became more serious, then. He frowned a bit, tilting his head to the side slightly. He shifted so that one of his hands supported his head on the mattress, and Katsuki shifted as well so that he could face Izuku better in that lying-down position. He knew he should feel awkward with the proximity, but the truth was he had already gone as far as cuddling with Izuku in his ghost form, so lying side-by-side after they spent a month sharing a bed didn’t feel as weird as it could have felt. If anything, it felt familiar, and nostalgic – it had been so long since they had last done this. If Izuku was uncomfortable with the closeness, he didn’t show it.

“To be really honest, Kacchan… I don’t”, Izuku admitted quietly.

Katsuki looked away. He didn’t want to talk about it, but he owned Deku as much. Wasn’t being honest with his feelings and with others something Doctor Matsuo always claimed would make him feel better?

“I thought you would hate me for taking your quirk”, Katsuki said in a low voice to prevent being overheard, not meeting Izuku’s eyes. His face looked very stern and serious, with a hint of disdain to it that was more of a defense mechanism than anything else. “I never thought you would actually buy me an expensive gift, I mean – who the fuck does that?”, he scoffed.

There was a beat. Izuku was watching him with attention, waiting. Katsuki went back to staring at the ceiling, stoic.

“When you said you wanted to talk, I thought you would tell me you never wanted to see me again. Because of that”.

He could feel Izuku’s eyes glued on him, but he couldn’t meet them.

A long time passed.

“You’ve really changed”, was Izuku’s response, and ok, Katsuki had to look at him now.

He turned his head to face Deku again. He was silent, questioning, and Izuku took that as an indication to continue, pensive.

“I mean… I don’t remember what happened. All Might says I will, after I get... You know what back. But he filled me in with what he knew”.

Katsuki nodded, indicating for him to continue.

“And… Well. I just – I never…”, Izuku hesitated, trailing off. He gazed downwards.

“Never what?”, Katsuki urged.

“I never knew you cared about me”, he admitted, voice quiet, eyes hidden from Katsuki.

There was silence for a while.

“I don’t think I did before”, Katsuki shrugged. Izuku looked up at him, and their eyes locked. “But I do, now”.

A pregnant pause.

“I don’t think we could have gone through everything we did without me caring about you. And yes, there’s still a part of me that calls me stupid for it, because I spent so long thinking that you looked down on me that it’s hard to just… stop thinking like that. Like you’re the enemy”.

Izuku frowned.

“But now I know better”, he concluded, stern, in a way that told Izuku that yes, he was being honest and open and fuck him to hell if he tried to make fun of his vulnerability.

“You do?”, Izuku asked, something akin to hope erupting in his tone.

“Deku, you bought the guy who bullied you for being quirkless and who then proceeded to steal your quirk an expensive-as-fuck Christmas present”, Katsuki rolled his eyes, keeping his voice low lest Inko heard the words. “That ain’t despising me, it’s just being stupid”.

Izuku narrowed his eyes in offense.

“*Hey*”.

“What? I’m being serious”, Katsuki shrugged.

“Yeah. I know you are”, Izuku smiled briefly, before his face became more sober. “But I didn’t buy you that because of… *OFA*”, he spelled, sparing the closed door of his room a wary look. “I did it because you saved my life, and I wanted to thank you for it”.

“You don’t have to thank me for it”, Katsuki scoffed. “It isn’t like I was about to let you drop dead”.

“Still”, Izuku shrugged. “I know it must have been hard, so I wanted to thank you”.

“And you’ll have to find another way to do it, because I’m not taking your present”.

“*Kacchan*”.

“I’m being serious, Deku”, Katsuki scoffed. “I won’t take it. If you want to give me a Christmas present so bad, find something cheaper. Also, I know how you’re *dying* to be the only All Might fan to have not one, but *two* of his rarest Golden Era figurines, so stop fucking insisting and just take what you can get”.

Izuku blushed slightly and lowered his head a bit in embarrassment.

“*Fine*”, he relented quietly, sounding almost ashamed. “But just because it’s really rare”.

Katsuki smirked wickedly.

“There. You’re fucking welcome”.

“I’ll think of another present for you, though”, he reassured.

“Don’t break a sweat over it”.

“I’ll do it”.

“Whatever, nerd”, Katsuki sighed.

There was comfortable silence for a while.

“Were we…”, Izuku started, pensive. Katsuki met his eyes again.

Izuku hesitated. He looked uncertain, but determined. He licked his lips and gathered the courage to continue.

“Were we… friends? Back when I was a ghost?”

Katsuki scoffed.

“Tch. What sort of question is that?”

“I don’t know”, Izuku shrugged. “It’s just… You’ve been so different. I was really confused, at first”.

Katsuki’s lips formed a stern line.

“So, I thought something must have happened, when we were together. Something must have changed”.

Katsuki sighed.

“You’ll remember everything, eventually”.

Izuku nodded.

“I know that. But can you tell me?”

Katsuki glared at him, squinting his eyes.

“It’s hard to explain”, he said, defensive. Izuku nodded without missing a beat.

“I can imagine that”.

A pause. Katsuki sniffed and twisted his nose. Izuku hadn’t insisted, but Katsuki knew he hadn’t dropped the subject, either.

“Why do you want to know so badly?”

Izuku shrugged again, the pink hue of embarrassment still tinging his freckled cheeks.

“I’m just trying to figure some things out”.

“What things?”

“I don’t know”, Izuku shrugged for the hundredth time. “Some things”.

Katsuki closed his eyes for a brief second and sighed deeply, trying to keep his cool and to find patience inside him. When he reopened them, he found Izuku’s expectant green eyes glued to him.

Fuck.

Whatever. He owned the nerd this much, after months of lies and omissions and half-truths.

“Fine, nerd. What do you want to know?”

Izuku smiled.

Katsuki would remember that moment with accurate precision months later, as he lies beneath the rubble of a crushed building and stares up at the dusty, bright sky above him through a space between the debris. The red of the fire that surrounds him is the exact opposite of Izuku’s green eyes, like the law of complementary colors, in which green and red are perfect opposites of each other, and they complete each other, but in Katsuki’s concussed mind, he can see it: the admiration in green, and the freckles, and the blush, and Deku’s green hair splayed around his head like a halo, touching Katsuki’s own cheek from the proximity and making it itch.

He would remember how Deku had laughed as he retold the events of Kirishima's birthday party, with the game and the stupid beers, and how he had blushed at the revelation that they had shared a bed (minus the cuddling part), and how serious he had looked as he learned the details of how Katsuki lost his hearing.

He would remember the flash of hurt in Deku's green eyes as he called him a *quirkless loser* and told him to stay the fuck back because he couldn't help – he would end up hurting himself, he needed to get out of there. He would remember Deku's laughing fit because of the identical Christmas gifts that hit him so hard he had to lie down in order to catch his breath. He would remember the exact sound of his laughter, and of his excited voice calling him *Kacchan*, even if he couldn't hear anything past the ringing of his ears at the moment, his hearing aid shattered to pieces beside his bleeding head.

And as he drifted off, eyelids too heavy to stay open, eyes too glazy to make sense of the blurring fire and the dust and the hint of the pink sky so many miles above him, Katsuki would dream of Izuku, as he had been doing for months now.

Chapter End Notes

Today marks one year since I first published this story!! Hooray!!
So much has changed in this meantime! I got a fulltime job, found an advisor for my thesis… And it still feels like it was yesterday I decided to start writing this story! Surprisingly enough, I still feel as excited about writing it than when I first started it, even if don't have as much time now! And you guys' support is one of the major reasons behind that; I don't think I would have been able to carry out this huge-ass project (I definitely didn't expect it to turn out so big) if it wasn't for your encouraging comments and your support, so thank you very much for taking the time to read this and for leaving nice comments!
This chapter was brought to you by a desperate author who doesn't want to rush development and ends up writing more than they had first planned. This one was actually gonna be way longer (like, twice this size), so I decided to be reasonable and cut it in half… But I did leave you guys a little taste of what's to come in the next chapter :3
By the way, the next chapter is the one with the scene that inspired me to write this whole story so hm… :-) be prepared :-) (it was gonna be in this chapter but c'mon this bad boy is nearly 20K already)
Golly, writing bakugrowth is a handful. I hope you guys like it, though ^-^

In other news, the amazing @cheseformice1 contacted me a while back on twitter asking if it would be ok to draw my story, which is an idea I absolutely loved and said yes to! You can check out their progress and their other work here: https://www.deviantart.com/cheseformice/art/The-Way-You-Used-To-Do-1--814821643. Leave them a nice comment if you enjoy their art!

The title of this chapter is a verse from *I Don't Know How To Love Him*, which is a song in the musical "Jesus Christ Superstar" (because I'm a slut for musicals).

Also, I totally based Mitsuki and her interactions with Katsuki on my own relationship/arguments with my mom. I'll dive deeper into her relationship with Katsuki in the future chapters!

Chapter 21: Spring Awakening, Spring Decay

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku was panting and sweating as he collapsed on the floor, the impact sending a sharp jolt across his extremities. Before he could catch his breath, however, a fist hurled towards his head, and he barely had enough time to dodge the blow and roll on his side before Katsuki's knuckles collided with the floor beside his head, hitting the exact spot where his face had been just a millisecond before.

He didn't have enough time or the chance to think as he jumped back to his feet with a half-grunt half-yelp, stumbling heavily from the rapidness of the movement and nearly falling on his butt again. Before he could regain his balance, Katsuki was already jumping at him, throwing himself against Izuku and enveloping his waist with his arms as he sent them both to the floor again. Izuku collapsed on his back with a breathless "oof", his ribs aching as they were compressed by Katsuki's weight.

Although the training mat's flooring was supposed to be smoother for the exact purpose of preventing injuries, Izuku's body was still too thin and not muscular enough to keep his bones from aching and rattling every time he made harsh contact with the ground – which was happening way more often than he would like –, *especially* when he had a whole human pressing down against him.

Katsuki sat on the top of him in a much too familiar pose – Izuku couldn't help but to think back to their fight after All Might's downfall, of how Katsuki had used him as a way to relieve his stress and his guilt –, and now he had one hand holding Izuku's head down so he couldn't move it while the other immobilized his arms above his head with a firm grip on his wrists.

Izuku panted heavily, trying to squirm away from the hold and failing. He turned his eyes to stare at the stoic face above him as best as he could, since he couldn't move his head.

It was truly remarkable how Kacchan managed to keep a straight face while training. Although Izuku could spot the sweat over his brow – the tiny droplets running down his temples and making the skin of his bare arms glisten; the sweet smell of nitroglycerin emanating from him almost intoxicating – his face was stern and emotionless, except for the eyes.

If it weren't for the blazing fury in the crimson eyes, Izuku might have mistaken Katsuki for a statue. Not a single wrinkle could be found in that stoic face, not a single trace of effort, tiredness, or smugness. Fury or victory weren't maiming Katsuki's stoic expression as it was his usual, and his eyes were the only part of his face that was expressing any emotion at all.

It was in the eyes Izuku found Kacchan – the challenge in them, the determination, the everlasting anger. He found himself staring fixedly at crimson, taking in how absolutely ablaze Katsuki's eyes looked – lively, and sparking, and raw with emotion, even if his face

was stoic. Just when he came to the realization that *ok, this is getting way too awkward now I should stop staring –,* Kacchan let go of his arms and his head abruptly, getting back to his feet before Izuku could make sense of what was happening or feel embarrassed for staring too long.

"Again", Katsuki said simply, shortly, walking to the farthest edge of the training mat and only then sparing Izuku a second glance.

Izuku just lied there for a second, still panting, before throwing his head back and squeezing his eyes shut with a tired sigh. Forcing himself back to his wobbly feet with a groan, he limped to the opposite side of the mat, diametrically away from his opponent. Even though training with Kacchan was a constant part of his routine, now, Izuku couldn't say it didn't leave him tired, especially with the rest of his agenda, and he struggled to keep his back straight and his posture upright as he raised his fists up to his chest in defiance.

School had started again almost a semester ago, and things were… Well. Things were going *great*, actually. He couldn't say he and Kacchan had entered a status of being *best* friends – if anything, more often than not, it was hard to say they were even friends to begin with. But something in their relationship had definitely shifted in those past six months, after that day in Izuku's apartment. Scenes like that of that day – lying on his bed and chatting, laughing, or simply hanging out – became more common. Their dynamic was nicer, yes, and they had engaged into more conversation and friendly banter than they had ever done in a *decade*, but that wasn't just it.

There was something new, unspeakable, and utterly *exciting* about this new thing he had with Kacchan. For starters, the bullying was over. While he still called Izuku names every now and then and was still overall pretty harsh, there was something different about his behavior – and maybe all this grumpiness and harshness was just Kacchan's personality, at the end of the day. Izuku saw the boy acting like that with Kirishima and Kaminari more often than not, and they were his friends, right? So maybe… maybe that was just how Kacchan was. And it wasn't like the thought of Kacchan being anything other than *angry* didn't send shivers down Izuku's spine. That was the only Kacchan he knew, and the only Kacchan he could deal with.

And yet, just the mere thought of Kacchan being actually gentle and tender to him for once, of Kacchan's fingers running up and down his back or nesting on the back of his head or caressing his cheek or massaging his shoulders or…

Uh… He'd – He'd rather not think about any of that.

(Why daydream about things that would never happen?)

If anything, Izuku couldn't deny that however harsh Kacchan may be, the fact that they were closer made him happy. Over the course of the semester, he learned not to think too much about Kacchan calling him a stupid nerd and variations thereof. He learned how to interpret Kacchan shoving him around or ruffling his hair so hard that he lost balance as a friendly gesture. He'd always been somewhat a brute, after all – and from what Izuku observed of his relationship with other people, especially with Kirishima, he could tell that being a bit too harsh was just how Kacchan expressed affection.

Kacchan still told him to *shut the hell up* and *stop mumbling* during classes, but he also stopped by during the afternoons and leant his notes to Izuku whenever he had to skip class because he was feeling too sick or too tired. Kacchan still asked him if his mom had dropped him on his head as a baby every now and then, but he also came over to practice his sign language skills with Izuku. He still made fun of him and mocked his All Might posters all over the wall, but he also sat with Izuku to keep him company whenever he got sick because of his still recovering immune system (even if he complained about it). He still called Izuku a *deku*, but he no longer seemed to perceive Izuku as useless. At least, that was what Izuku liked to think, as he stared up at his wall at night wondering and wondering and wondering for hours about his daily interactions with Kacchan.

It was hard to say that they were proper *friends* by the definition of the word, but somehow, Izuku knew they were. In their own way, at least. Maybe this was their own definition of friendship – *Kacchan's* own definition of friendship. An adaptation of the concept that could fit what they both had; a variation of sorts that was and was not a proper friendship per say, but it was *their* friendship. At the end of the day, they were definitely closer, and Izuku wasn't about to complain – he would take everything and anything he could get. Plus, Kacchan was undeniably different, so maybe that was a good sign.

He was different and yet the same, actually. Because so much about him and his behavior towards Izuku had changed, and yet he was still the same Kacchan Izuku had known all his life. So what if he seemed to care about Izuku, now? He was still as fierce, determined, and arrogant as ever. So what if he acted like they were actually friends for the first time in their lives? He still called Izuku names, and teased him, and provoked him.

Izuku had told him, back on that Christmas day at his house, that he would permanently forgive Kacchan under one condition, and one condition only: he wasn't allowed to call him "quirkless" again. Kacchan could call him whatever he wanted and act however he wanted, but he couldn't use that specific word anymore, under penalty of having Izuku stop talking to him altogether.

It was a silly thing, really, and Izuku knew Kacchan wouldn't be as cold as to call him *that,* given the circumstances that had made him lose his quirk – and the own fear Kacchan himself admitted to feeling; a fear that Izuku would hate him for what he had done. This was a sensitive subject for both of them, even if it hurt Izuku more, so he knew Kacchan wouldn't use it against him – not after everything that they had gone through, and everything that had changed in their relationship. But at the end of the day, Izuku was better safe than sorry – especially because he *really* needed Kacchan to comprehend that, while he understood the reason why he had taken his quirk, the implication of that action and the weight it carried was too heavy to go unmentioned, *especially* after everything Kacchan had put Izuku through during their childhoods.

That specific word carried years of abuse and pain and sorrow and isolation, and while Izuku could acknowledge that Kacchan had meant no harm in taking One For All from him – he had done it to *save his life* –, calling him *quirkless* would reopen a years-long wound, a wound which Izuku decided to overlook due to the inevitability of Kacchan's decision to save his life.

He knew Kacchan didn't have a choice when he ate his hair. Izuku could understand that he made him quirkless once more for the sake of his well-being, for the sake of his *life* – but he wouldn't be able to forgive the boy if he shoved it on his face. It would be just too hard, and the use of the word would recreate that uncrossable bridge between them – a bridge they had struggled to overcome for years.

Just pray that you'll be born with a quirk in your next life and take a swan dive off the roof of the building.

To Izuku's surprise, Kacchan hadn't mocked him, or teased him, or complained about his request at all – he had merely nodded, serious, silent, comprehending. He seemed to understand how sensitive that subject was for Izuku, and he never acted like it was an exaggeration on his part to request that – another evidence of how he had changed and matured over the past months, no matter how harsh and short-tempered he remained.

Overall, Izuku felt like this was the best version of Kacchan he could possibly get – still the same, but better. He still had all the traces Izuku had spent his life admiring; he still had that fierce, explosive personality Izuku knew so well, and now – now he actually gave Izuku the time of the day. As if they were equals. As if they *could* be equals. Everything was perfect, really.

And yet… Izuku couldn't help but to feel like there was something wrong.

He had convinced himself, over the course of the six months that passed ever since he made peace with Kacchan, that this uneasy feeling he couldn't help but to feel was nothing more than his memory loss taking its toll on him. Even though everything was great with Kacchan and he was getting better and stronger with each passing day, despite a few setbacks, there was still a month-long gap in his memory – a gap which he could only fill with things other people told him, and not with his own thoughts and memories. Kacchan had answered all his questions and doubts back at Christmas – even when Izuku couldn't fully comprehend what he was being told –, but he couldn't help but to feel like there was something still missing – something still looming at the back of his mind, hidden by shadows, smothered by his amnesia.

(Something that made his chest ache whenever he looked at Kacchan.)

That *something* was his memory, it *had* to be – and it was also the absence of One For All, *yes*, yes, he knew, but he couldn't help but to feel… He couldn't help but to feel apprehensive. And a bit scared, also; not that he would admit aloud. All Might had assured him that he would be able to get One For All passed back to him once his body was ready to endure it again (therefore putting an end to Izuku's greatest fear so far), and also that his memories from his time as a ghost would return along with it (which was definitely reassuring). But there was still *something* about this whole ordeal that made Izuku uneasy and almost anxious. He couldn't quite put his finger on what it was, but he knew there was something.

There wasn't much he could do about it, though. That was a fact he had learned to accept months ago, ever since All Might sat down with him and explained what had happened after he had barged out of the students' dorm and left Kacchan behind. Until he got One For All

back and regained his memories, there was nothing he could do other than take care of his health and train in order to get better. Worrying about it would only make his recovery harder and slower, so he opted to accept the small mercies in life and indulge in Kacchan's version of attention and friendliness – something he had never been granted access to for the vast majority of his life, no matter how badly he had longed for it.

So yes, Izuku had already come to terms with the fact that there was nothing he could do other than wait and do his best to get better soon, but *boy*, he had never expected that his recovery would take so *long*. He was nearing the one-year-mark since he first woke up from the coma, and he was *still* going through recovery. Apparently, spending a whole month with no soul inside his body and then dying for a minute took more of a toll on him than anyone expected, and during his time as a ghost his body had lost more than half of his previous muscle mass. Even though he was definitely stronger now, his body still wasn't strong enough to endure One For All just yet, and it also wasn't strong enough to undergo the same type of training All Might had given him back before he entered UA.

The undeniable truth was that Izuku *did* need to take things slow, since rushing his recovery would do more harm than good at this point. He was following the diet All Might had made for him to the letter, he was taking his medicine daily, he was doing moderate physical exercise. Over the course of the previous months, as he slowly started to regain his health, Kacchan offered to help him train so that he could improve his body's compromised coordination again, and Izuku had eagerly accepted. Overall, he was taking good care of his recovering body, and while he still got sick every now and then (because he couldn't have everything in life, could he?), this type of incident was becoming less often.

All Might was also doing some training with him – nothing like the first time, before Izuku took One For All, but rather a lighter version of it –, meaning to aid him in the arduous quest of recovering his lost muscle mass. And although things were mostly going great when it came to regaining his health, Izuku had to admit they were a bit crappy when it came to regaining his muscle mass. Yes, he was definitely doing better now, as the end of the semester approached them, than he had been doing in the previous one, but he was still too thin and too weak, even if he had been cleared out of physiotherapy. He was still not buff enough, despite his diet and his constant working-out sessions. His hands still shook and his legs still cramped whenever he tried to overdo himself. He still had a lot of work ahead of him before he could take One For All back, and the delay was driving him *insane*.

Not that he didn't adore his training sessions with All Might and with Kacchan. Having the boy offer him that opportunity was more than Izuku could have ever dared to dream of during his childhood. Not only did the sessions give them some quality time to develop their growing friendship, but they also did a good job in aiding his recovery, however slow it was.

Kacchan was an excellent teacher, and he seemed to be particularly talented in pinpointing just the precise thing Izuku needed to work harder on, or to improve, or to develop. He excelled at scanning all his flaws and using them against him during their sparring, which, on one hand, *sucked*, because it meant Izuku spent a lot of time faceplanted on the floor while Kacchan immobilized him, but on the other hand was great, because it meant Izuku could use the experience to learn and work harder on overcoming his flaws. So while the training sessions with Kacchan usually left him exhausted and with purple bruises painting his entire

body, they also left him closer and closer to full recovery and the ultimate returning of his quirk.

Also, it wasn't like Kacchan was trying to actively hurt him or give him bruises. Izuku knew Kacchan like the back of his hand, even if they hadn't been this close before: he knew his tactics. He could tell when Kacchan pulled his punches, which he did a lot during their training. Izuku's bruises were a result of his weakened body, not of Kacchan's fists – which was yet another reason why he was so frustrated with the sheer amount of *time* it was taking him to get better.

His issue with the delay in getting better wasn't having to spend more time with Kacchan – if anything, that was definitely the *best* part of the delay, and the only thing that made it worth it. His issue with the delay was that it left him feeling trapped inside his own body.

Izuku was an observant person. He was attentive, and careful, and he had a strategical, analytical brain. The ridiculous amount of hero analysis notebooks he owned was proof of that. One week after training with Kacchan and he could already predict almost every single one of his moves, of his attacks, of his offenses – which arm he preferred to attack with first, the way he positioned his feet on the mat before he charged, the slight squint of his eyes as he strategized his next move. If Izuku had already been good at analyzing Kacchan back when they barely spoke with each other, now he could read Kacchan like an open book, since they trained together every week. And yet, despite all this, despite everything… He still couldn't urge his body to respond in time.

He was getting better at blocking Kacchan's attacks, but it was still hard to dodge them or to counter-attack, no matter how fast his brain went. Izuku felt out of synchrony with his own body, as if his brain and his limbs were working at a different frame rate. He knew everything he was supposed to do in order to win, every single step he needed to follow in order to defeat Kacchan, but he still couldn't bring his shaking, stupid bony arms to do it; he still couldn't bring his trembling, tired legs to obey him. If anything, this made him feel even more frustrated and miserable about his current situation, and it only made his desire to get fully better already become stronger and more intense.

Basically, this is what his routine had come to, now: go to classes, have a healthy, balanced lunch with his friends, train with Kacchan, train with All Might, do some studying, go to sleep. Sometimes have sign language practice with Kacchan in-between, sometimes hang out with his friends on other occasions. Every now and then he got sick again, and it totally sucked but he had learned how to deal with it. Mostly, he just spent most of his days wishing he could get better already. The only thing that kept him from feeling bad about *wishing* so hard was the fact that he was actually working for it – he was actively doing everything he could to achieve his goal, no matter how hard it was somedays.

Aizawa sensei had been very comprehensive when Izuku, with All Might's aid, explained the situation of his recovery to him and justified why he wouldn't be able to take part in quirk-demanding classes until he was back to 100%. If anything, the very last thing Aizawa sensei needed was for Izuku to break his bones every other day and keep getting constantly injured before he could make a full recovery, with everything else he was already going through – *a step back*, as he had called it.

Because of this, Izuku had been cleared out of all quirk-practice classes as a precaution, and thus he would need to take an evaluative exam once he was back to his full health. The exam would dictate whether or not he would be able to continue taking classes with his friends or if he would need to take the semester again with a different class. Hence why his training with Kacchan was also important, even if they didn't use quirks: Izuku needed to keep himself at the top if he didn't want to fall behind – or even *more* behind –, and what better person to help him than the best of the best himself?

This was why, despite his exhaustion, Izuku raised his fists to the height of his chest, staring at Kacchan with defiance, and gestured at him to charge.

Katsuki smirked.

They started sparring again, Izuku successfully hitting a couple of blows against Katsuki's stomach and dodging one of Katsuki's incoming attacks, before a pair of sweaty hands grabbed his left arm and the world tilted. When Izuku regained his balance, he was on his back on the mat again, arms pinned by Katsuki's hands above his head, the boy sitting on his lap to pin him down to the floor exactly like he had done mere moments before.

Izuku sighed and threw his head back with a frustrated groan. He *really* needed to work protecting his left flank.

"You need to work on protecting your left flank", Katsuki said in a perfect mimicking of his thoughts, face as stoic as ever. Izuku's eyes widened a bit, but Katsuki didn't seem to notice.

"I know", Izuku said with a resigned tone, relaxing under Katsuki since he knew he was nowhere near the required shape to free himself from the boy's hold. "I'll work on it".

"Of course you will", Katsuki scoffed as if Izuku had just said the most stupid thing ever. "Right fucking now. Come on", he released his grasp on Izuku and got to his feet again, repeating what he had done and walking back to the far end of the mat.

Izuku groaned as he struggled to get up, already feeling worn out. He walked to the opposite side and raised his fists again.

This time, it was nearly pathetic. Izuku only managed to get one blow in before Katsuki was sending him to the floor again, climbing on the top of him again, and pinning his hands above his head *again*. Izuku sighed and closed his eyes.

"*Oi*. What the *fuck* do you think you're doing?", Katsuki asked impatiently, and Izuku opened his eyes to find the so-far stoic face contorted in an annoyed grimace. Upon the look on Izuku's face, Katsuki's expression shifted into suspicion. "Are you losing on purpose?"

"*No*", Izuku answered too fast, feeling heat rising to his cheeks. "Why w-would I do that, Kacchan, that – t-that doesn't even –"

"Then *stop* making it so easy", Katsuki huffed, annoyed. He tightened his grip on Izuku's wrists and bent over so that his face was closer to the boy's, his weight crushing harder into Izuku as their stomachs became airtight connected. Izuku swallowed dry, feeling the heat and

the sweat of Kacchan's skin contacting with his with sharp attention. "It's like you're not even making an effort, shitty Deku. Why the fuck do you keep relaxing after I immobilize you? If you're facing an opponent who's coming at you with everything he has, he won't make it as easy as I am", he tightened his grip on Izuku's wrists even more as if to prove his point.

"I – I know", Izuku said, nervous and ashamedly aware that his face must have been the same color as a tomato. "I'll work on it, maybe even talk to All –"

"Free yourself", Katsuki cut him off, authority all over his tone.

"*What*", Izuku basically wheezed, dread and something warm pooling at the bottom of his stomach.

"I said free yourself. Go on. You're on a fight and a villain takes you down, like I did", Katsuki said. "He's using his body weight to pin your waist down, so using your legs isn't an option. He grabbed your wrists like this", he squeezed again, "and pinned them up your head. Watcha gonna do?"

Izuku's heart was racing inside his chest.

"K-Kacchan, I –"

"He's about to kill you. Watcha gonna do, Deku?", Katsuki interrupted again. "You've got no backup, no comms, nothing".

Katsuki leaned forwards again, more of his weight pressing against Izuku, who couldn't help but to yelp in response at the pressure. When Katsuki spoke again, his voice was hoarse, dangerous, and barely above a whisper.

"How are you going to get free?", he asked, voice low.

Izuku stared at him, eyes darting frantically between Kacchan's crimson ones. Kacchan's face was back to stoicism, waiting to see what Izuku would do, how he would respond, how he would get free. And Izuku was feeling tired and worn out, but he couldn't just tell Kacchan he would give up, right? He was training to be a hero. He couldn't just *give up* and let his adversary win.

Izuku squirmed and struggled underneath Katsuki's weight, grunting and panting, trying to free his arms and failing. Katsuki's grip on his wrists was unfaltering, and it would be impossible to use them to engage in an offensive attack in that angle. He then tried squirming and wiggling his hips in an attempt to dislodge Katsuki enough so that he would be able to lock his legs around Katsuki's waist and use his weight shift their positions, but the boy was heavy and his weight over Izuku's crotch was unmovable.

Izuku started to pant more heavily, getting nervous that none of his two attempts to move his opponent had worked. But he couldn't give up. He *wouldn't* give up.

The only limb that could still move freely and that was not restrained was his head, so he decided to use that to his advantage. Katsuki was watching him with sharp attention, the hint of a petulant smirk starting to blossom at the corner of his lips at his apparent victory. He looked confident that he had won, and Izuku decided to use that to his advantage too.

He sighed heavily, allowing his body to relax beneath Katsuki again and closing his eyes. Katsuki snorted out a breath that could be described as victorious.

“Giving up that easily, Deku?”, he mocked. “You’re not making it too hard for me to become number one”.

Izuku let out a deep breath and moved his lips as if he was speaking, no voice escaping through them. Katsuki frowned.

“What?”, he asked, instinctively leaning his head a bit closer to Izuku so that he could hear him.

“K-Kacchan, I don’t…”, he said, opening his eyes. His voice was a bit louder but still barely above a whisper.

Their faces were really close to one another now, the tips of their noses nearly touching. Izuku licked his lips as if to moisturize them before he could repeat himself, and in a moment of distraction Katsuki found his eyes averting downwards to stare at the parted lips against his will –

Slam. Izuku took the distraction to headbutt Katsuki, making him release his grip on his wrists for a second. The surprise attack caused enough of a window for Izuku to push Katsuki’s chest at full force, shoving him away from himself as the explosive boy shot a hand up to press at his now split lip. Katsuki lost balance and collapsed on his side, and Izuku wasted no time into pushing the boy on his back and climbing on top of him, like Katsuki himself had done, pining Katsuki’s hands above his head and using his weight to pin him down in a perfect inversion of their positions from just a mere moment ago.

“This is how I’m gonna get free”, he smiled happily, a stark contrast to Katsuki’s stoicism in front of victory. Katsuki was glaring daggers at him, looking furious, a bit of blood escaping from the cut Izuku’s forehead had opened on his lower lip.

“You *fucker*”, he barked, snarling, clearly angry at having been so easily fooled.

“What? I took your disadvantage and used it against you”, Izuku shrugged, his face too gleeful.

Finally, something he had done had worked. Finally, his body had obeyed him! Finally, he had won! He *did* feel a little bad for using Kacchan’s compromised hearing against him in a fight, but hey, Kacchan had been using all of Izuku’s fragilities against him this *entire* time, so it was only fair, right? He was allowed to win once. His gleefulness made him start ranting in spite of himself.

“It’s just what you’ve been doing to me this entire time, if you think about it. But this only proves how good of a teacher you are, Kacchan! And I’m not saying this to be mean or to ‘shove it on your face’ or whatever it is you’re thinking; I actually mean it. You should be proud of yourself, since this is proof that your teaching methods have been – aaah!”, he exclaimed in surprise as Katsuki easily thrusted his hip upwards at full force against Izuku’s bum, lifting the boy’s knees off the ground and making him lose balance. Izuku toppled to the side and turned to lie on his back, but before he could get up, Katsuki was already placing himself atop him once more.

This time, Katsuki didn’t use his weight to pin Izuku’s waist to the floor, instead getting on all fours above him. His right knee rested on the mat beside Izuku’s right hip, the left one rested on the mat beside Izuku’s left hip. Each of his hands pinned Izuku’s wrists tightly to the floor, and he looked *furious* as he loomed above him. Actually, he looked almost feral, in a way; the deep red of the already congealing blood on his lower lip matching the crimson of his angry eyes perfectly.

Izuku tried to take the fact that Kacchan was no longer sitting on him to his advantage and kick him away, but his feet barely did anything to move the boy. Then, panting, he attempted to lock his legs around Katsuki’s waist and spin him around to reverse their positions again, but Katsuki didn’t budge. Instead, he simply narrowed his eyes at Izuku, his grip on his wrists becoming tighter.

Izuku unlocked his legs from Katsuki’s hips, allowing himself to relax in defeat. Katsuki didn’t need to pin Izuku down with his full weight for the boy to know that this was over – there was no escaping Kacchan anymore.

“That was cute, nerd, but you didn’t take something into consideration”, he scoffed once Izuku gave up, voice low and hoarse, almost menacing. “I’m heavy enough to pin you down. As for you…”, he shrugged.

Izuku stared up at him, cheeks flushing in embarrassment again. He suddenly felt weak and humiliated – he had really thought he had been close to defeating Kacchan, but his weakness had stopped him yet again. He looked away, no longer able to meet Katsuki’s eyes.

They stayed like that for a few seconds that felt like an eternity.

“Let’s call it a day. I think you learned your lesson”, Katsuki said, putting an end to the awkward silence and releasing Izuku one final time. He got to his feet.

Before Izuku could even think of attempting to get up, Katsuki grabbed one of his arms and basically yanked him to his feet with no apparent effort. Izuku collapsed against his chest because of the momentum, and Katsuki held him in place with a hand on his waist as he regained his balance and made sense of his sudden change in position. The lack of effort in the gesture only served to remind Izuku of how thin he was still, and how far he was from his complete recovery. He felt frustrated and pathetic, all at the same time, and suddenly he wanted nothing more than to go to his room and forget about this disappointing turn of events.

Not meeting Kacchan's eyes, he gently broke their touch and walked off the mat, heading to the chair where he had left his things and grabbing himself a towel. From his peripheral vision, he could see Kacchan following him out and doing the same, but he didn't dare to look at him. For once, he didn't feel comfortable seeing the smug victory in those crimson eyes, lest he be reminded of his own defeat.

He used the towel to dry his forehead and his chest, feeling once again exhausted now that the adrenaline of the sparring was no longer fueling him. Izuku wanted nothing more than to take a nice, hot shower, get some sleep, and *maybe* work out an alternative to escaping Kacchan's relentless grip without having to count on his ridiculously low body weight or his mostly absent strength.

He felt quirkless again. Well – he *was* quirkless again, but he felt like he was back to what life used to be before he met All Might, back to mark 0: weak, and helpless, and unable to fend for himself or to anyone else.

"Oi. Nerd", Katsuki called him after a few moments, and Izuku turned to look at him out of instinct, without really having to think about it. As soon as their eyes met, Izuku averted his gaze to Katsuki's feet.

Katsuki scoffed, possibly sensing his discomfort and taking a step closer to him. Izuku met his eyes again, aware that his frustration and humiliation for not being able to do something as simple as escaping must have been evident.

If anything, Katsuki's own look was unreadable, but there was no mockery in his tone when he said:

"Nice move".

Izuku blinked, taken aback.

"It caught me off guard, and the whole pinning-me-down thing might have worked if you were heavier", Kacchan complimented.

And hell, Izuku felt ridiculous for the way his heartbeat sped up and his eyes sparkled from something as simple as a *compliment* from Kacchan. Hearing praise coming from him was so unusual and rare that Izuku couldn't help but to feel like an addict – it made him feel high, and the more he got, the more he longed for it. His sour mood completely shifted just from hearing those simple words, and it must have shown in his face, because Katsuki gave him a smirk and scoffed.

"But don't think too much of yourself just yet, asshat. If someone grabs you like while you're still weak and you pull that shit off, don't try to pin them down. You headbutt them and you run the hell away to get help, you understand?", he added sternly.

Izuku felt like disagreeing, but he knew Katsuki was right. While he was still weak and recovering, he needed to be careful, and even if he hated the idea of running away, he hated the idea of *dying* more. He could go back to defending himself on his own when he was healthy enough to do so.

"*Hai*", he said simply, nodding. Katsuki nodded as well and turned away, going back to drying himself up.

Izuku held his own towel with a slack hand in front of himself for a few pensive seconds before turning towards Katsuki again.

"How's your lip?", he asked, the sorrow evident in his voice. Katsuki rolled his eyes, not bothering to look at him.

"It's not a big deal. It will heal overnight", he replied simply.

"Are you sure?", Izuku frowned, taking a step closer to Katsuki. "I – I didn't mean to hurt you that bad, Kacchan, I'm sorry. Maybe you should go see Recovery Girl –"

"It's gonna take way more than your thick coconut head to send me to the old woman. I said I'm fine, so stop fucking worrying about it", he cut Izuku off with a warning glare. Izuku backed down, having learned in those past months that, when it came to Kacchan's health, it was better not to push it lest he unleash his fury.

"All right", he said, putting his towel back into his bag and picking it up, throwing it over his shoulder. "I'm still sorry, though".

"I know you are", Katsuki rolled his eyes again. "Like I said, don't worry about it".

A pause. Izuku simply stood there, bag on his shoulder and ready to leave, while Katsuki continued to dry himself with his towel. However, something seemed to be keeping him from simply walking out of the gym and getting his much desired – and deserved – sleep.

"You going back to the dorm?", Katsuki asked, turning to face Izuku with sharp eyes when he noticed the boy wasn't moving.

"Y-Yeah", Izuku nodded, feeling like he had been caught red-handed – though from what, he couldn't tell. He held back a yawn. "I really need a shower".

"I know. I could smell you", Katsuki scoffed with a serious face.

Izuku had learned, over the course of the past months, that Kacchan didn't usually change his face whenever he jested – he would say something rude as a joke and as an insult with the exact same expression on his face, which meant it was hard to tell when he meant something and when he didn't. This time, Izuku *could* tell – especially from the way Kacchan turned to give him a shit-eating smirk as if to make things clearer.

"*Hey*", Izuku protested just because, since there was humor in his eyes and on his lips.

"Go wash that stink off, Deku. And maybe get some sleep after you're done. You look like shit".

Izuku chuckled a tired laugh as he slowly walked past Katsuki and towards the door.

"I'm just tired", he shrugged absentmindedly. "You going back to the dorm too?"

“Nah. Imma do some training with Kirishima, now”, Katsuki said without looking at him, too busy fiddling with something inside his bag. Izuku’s face fell, and for once he was thankful Katsuki hadn’t bothered looking at him, lest he see the reaction.

His mind couldn’t help but to picture Kacchan sitting on all fours above Kirishima in a perfect mimic of what he had done to Izuku just a few minutes ago, their noses and lips millimeters apart from each other like his and Izuku’s had been, Kacchan pinning Kirishima’s hands above his head like he had done to him and smirking wickedly, victory sparkling in his eyes as their crotches and stomachs pressed against one another –

“I gotta get some *real* sparring done, right, Deku?”, Katsuki teased in a rather mean way, still oblivious of Izuku’s reaction.

His words should have stung because of the recent defeat Izuku had suffered at his hands, but in reality, they stung because of the implication of them – that having Izuku as an adversary was child’s play, or just a past time; that Izuku was no challenge at all; that Izuku wasn’t worthy. And Izuku knew – he *knew* that, in the state he was in, he presented to real challenge to Kacchan’s abilities, but he had allowed himself to hope that he wasn’t the only one getting something out of those matches – that Kacchan was profiting from them too. And apparently… he was wrong.

Izuku swallowed dry and lowered his head, and his silence caught Katsuki’s attention, making him finally turn his head to look. He frowned as he noticed the sadness in Izuku’s face.

“The fuck you got that look on for?”, Katsuki asked, confused. Izuku sighed, knowing where the confusion was coming from.

Once Kacchan started to be nicer and friendlier to him, he started to get better at interpreting Kacchan’s teasing for what it was. Izuku had stopped taking his words to heart all the time, even though some of them still hurt. And now, his reaction to his obvious teasing had gone back to what it used to be before they were in good terms, which was probably unexpected, to say the least. Knowing he would end up making things even weirder if he said nothing, Izuku scratched the back of his neck and shrugged.

“Nothing. I was just wondering…”, he trailed off, embarrassed and hesitant. Katsuki’s eyes were glued on him, now, his full attention focused on him.

There was no way he could get out of this one – he had dug his own grave. Izuku sighed again, not meeting Katsuki’s eyes as he hoped his question wouldn’t sound as weird out loud as it sounded inside his head.

“Do you – um. Do you train with Kirishima-kun the same way you train with me?”

Katsuki squinted, suspicion etched all over his face. He let go of his towel, letting it flop on the top of his bag, before he took a step closer to Izuku.

Izuku had no idea if Kacchan had understood the real meaning behind his question. A part of him wished he had, while the other desperately wished he hadn’t. As he waited for a

response, he anxiously thumbed the hem of his sweaty shirt, desperate to do something with his hands if only to relieve the stress of the awkward turn that conversation had taken. Kacchan approached him further, and with the proximity, Izuku could feel his heart beating faster and faster inside his chest.

He hoped he hadn't ruined that moment with Kacchan. He hoped he hadn't ruined his future sparring sessions with Kacchan by making the boy too self-conscious about what he was doing – climbing atop of him, pressing against his crotch, pinning Izuku down to the floor and looming so close to him they could feel each other's breaths. He hoped Kacchan wouldn't think of him differently, or stop doing what he always did. He hoped he hadn't ruined his friendship with Kacchan – oh, god, it had taken him so long to get to that point, it had taken him a literal *coma* to become closer to Kacchan, he really, really hoped he hadn't screwed everything up because of *one* single stupid question –

"No", Katsuki responded simply, naturally, and apparently unbothered, the simple answer sucker-punching Izuku out of his nervous stream of thoughts. "Shitty Hair's way better at defense than he is at offensive attacks, probably because of his quirk. So we gotta have a different dynamic for our training".

"O-Oh", Izuku responded simply, busying his hands by grasping the strands of his bag with a tight, awkward grip.

Katsuki narrowed his eyes at him in suspicion, but he didn't say anything else. He looked like he was trying to analyze Izuku and figure out why he had asked that question, which, *no*, thanks, Izuku didn't want to risk. That was his cue to get the hell out of there.

"Ok, I'll get going, now. Thanks for the sparring, Kacchan, I'll – I'll work on my left flank. Sorry again for – uh, for y-your lip".

"Already told you it's not a big deal", was Katsuki's only response, still suspicious, as Izuku turned on his heels and tried his best to walk in a normal speed towards the exit.

Before he reached the door, Katsuki called him.

"Hey".

Izuku stopped on his tracks, tightening his hands into fists and biting at his lower lip. He slowly turned on his heels in order to face Kacchan again, anticipation written all over his face. Kacchan's face was serious, his eyes intense.

"Y-Yeah?"

Katsuki watched him for a moment.

"Just tell me if you think this is becoming too much", he said. "I can go easier on you".

Izuku stared at him with a blank expression for a moment, before a shy smile blossomed on his lips. That was the exact opposite of what he wanted – Kacchan going *easier* on him –, but he had to admit it was nice and considerate of him to offer that.

“I know you can”, he said, a bit melancholic.

“I mean it, Deku”, Kacchan insisted, serious. “Last thing I want is to send you back to the damn hospital because I pushed you too far with this training shit. If you think this is becoming too much, you tell me, and we’ll figure something else out. We can always adapt”.

Izuku nodded, his smile widening but his eyes sad.

“Yeah. Ok”.

“If All Might beats my ass because you were too stupid to tell me when to stop, we’re gonna have a problem”.

“All Might is not the one you need to worry about, Kacchan”, Izuku chuckled, teasing. Yeah, that was good. Teasing was their new normal, he should stick to it. It was comforting; it relieved the tension.

“We’re not gonna have a problem if your mom beats my ass because I probably will never talk about it”, Katsuki scoffed.

Izuku’s eyebrows shot up.

“So you’re admitting my mom can defeat you? What happened to that whole ‘I will surpass you and become number one’ talk?”, Izuku teased.

“Fucking watch it, shitty Deku. You’re walking a thin line here”, Katsuki glared. “And learn how to take a damn compliment while you’re at it”.

Izuku chuckled fondly.

“I’ll see you tomorrow, Kacchan”.

“Yeah, whatever”.

Izuku turned on his heels again and left, a tiny smile painting the corners of his lips despite the sorrow in his eyes.

Once Deku was gone, Katsuki took two fingers to his throbbing lip pensively before going back to fiddling with the contents of his bag.

From: Ears

Ok hear me out

From: Bakugou

Starting your damn message like that makes me NOT want to hear you out

From: Ears

Stop it

From: Ears

I think you're going to like this

From: Bakugou

Just spit it

From: Ears

Ok, so we haven't had much time to practice in a while, right?

From: Ears

Momo didn't get to go to any of our practices last semester, now Tokoyami is very busy and I know that you are too

From: Bakugou

So you haven't been busy?

From: Bakugou

Holy shit Ears get a life

From: Ears

Shut up

From: Ears

What I mean is

From: Ears

The guys were talking about going to the spring festival downtown, right

From: Bakugou

Of course I know the answer to that question

From: Ears

Bakugou

From: Ears

Let me type and stop interrupting me

From: Bakugou

Not my fault you're a slow fucking typer

From: Ears

You're making me regret ever thinking of inviting you

From: Bakugou

Great. Now you'll leave me alone?

From: Ears

No. Consider this is as your punishment for being such a pain in the ass

From: Ears

As I was saying

From: Ears

Spring festival. Downtown. There's some sort of talent show there and I signed our band up

From: Ears

Before you complain about it, there was a deadline for the subscriptions and I wouldn't have the time to talk to everyone before I signed us up or I'd miss it. But think of it as a nice reunion for the band! Like that time we did the school festival!!

From: Bakugou

That sounds great, actually

From: Ears

Really??

From: Bakugou

Yeah. All you gotta do now is find a drummer for the band

From: Ears

I hate you so much

From: Ears

You're the drummer

From: Bakugou

You might want to double check that

From: Ears

I am double checking it right now

From: Ears

Come on. I'll let you choose half of our playlist

From: Bakugou

Yeah, that's a hard pass

From: Ears

Stop pretending you're not dying to play those angsty songs you've been hearing

From: Ears

The entire playlist, then? How does that sound?

From: Bakugou

Firstly, no, secondly, how the fuck do you know what I've been hearing

From: Ears

We've had this conversation. The app you use lets other people see what you're playing

From: Bakugou

Stalker

From: Bakugou

Wait. Anyone can see it?

From: Ears

No, just the people who follow you

From: Ears

I'll teach you all about it if you go to the spring festival with us

From: Bakugou

No

From: Ears

Bakugou COME ON

From: Ears

I've already signed us up and I really don't want to look for another drummer

From: Ears

Are you telling me that you want us to replace you with someone else? Someone who could happen to be even better than you and overshadow the fact that you were ever part of the band? And when we blow up and become successful no one will even remember you were in the original formation? Is THAT what you want?

From: Bakugou

If that means I won't have to perform in front of a bunch of useless extras in some unknown shitty festival then yes

From: Bakugou

Also I thought your dream job was to be a hero, not some wannabe rockstar

From: Ears

It's always nice to have a plan B

From: Ears

But what are you so afraid of?

From: Bakugou

I'm not afraid of shit

From: Ears

I know that Hatsume girl gave you an upgrade for your hearing aid and I know that you can wear it under the ear protection. You were doing amazing on our last practices. So what is this really about?

From: Bakugou

This is about me not wanting to perform with your shitty band in front of a bunch of people I don't know at a stupid spring festival

From: Bakugou

I'm not even going to that shit in the first place

From: Ears

Ugh, you know what, fine

From: Ears

I'll find another drummer, since you love being so difficult

From: Bakugou

Good luck with that

Katsuki closed the chat and set his phone down for a moment before picking it up again. After thinking for a few moments, he opened his music app and went to his profile, checking his list of followers. Not a lot of people, that was true, but most of his classmates were there. Well…

All of his classmates were there. And ~~he~~ they could see whatever shitty, angsty song Katsuki listened to.

He sighed and deleted the app.

"*So, I was thinking*", Deku signed at him. "*Are you going to the spring festival?*"

"*No*", Katsuki signed in response, shortly. Izuku frowned.

They were sitting on Izuku's bed, cross-legged and facing one another. This had become routine for them ever since they made peace and classes started again – Katsuki would come over to Izuku's bedroom and they would practice sign language for a while, usually just talking about meaningless stuff and hanging out with each other.

With the end of the trimester approaching them, however, they hadn't found much free time to do that – Katsuki too busy with studying and practicing for his quirk-required classes, which Izuku didn't have to attend for the time being, and Izuku still struggling to catch up with everything that he had lost.

This was the first time in weeks they had the chance to meet and practice sign language, and it was nice to talk to each other without having to use words, for once. They had seemed to find, in sign language, a different type of communication that they didn't have – *never had* – in their spoken conversations, and it was nice. It was *their* thing, something only the two of them shared, and seemingly the most effective way for them to communicate and sort out their problems when they had to.

Funnily enough, those encounters only ever took place in Izuku's bedroom. Thinking better about it, Katsuki didn't think Deku had ever entered his bedroom again after his soul was returned to his body.

Huh.

"*Why not?*", Izuku frowned, clearly surprised. Katsuki rolled his eyes.

"*Do I really look like the kind of person who attends this stupid shit?*"

Izuku frowned.

"*But everyone is going. And…*", he hesitated.

Katsuki squinted.

"*And what?*"

He hesitated, seeming conflicted.

"*Jirou-san told me you were going*", he shrugged after a few moments. Katsuki could sense that was not what Deku meant to say originally, but decided not to push it. "*She said you were going to play in the band. I was really looking forward to that*".

Katsuki saw red. What the fuck did Ears think she was doing, going around and spreading lies about him like that?

"*She told you that?*"

"*Yes. I was really excited. Actually…*"

Katsuki glared at him. Izuku shrugged.

"*I was the one who told her about the talent show. My mom got a flyer when she was making her groceries and she sent a picture to me. I thought it would be nice if you guys played there, since you have a band and you still practice sometimes, so… Well. I told Jirou-san about it, she said she would sign you guys up, since the deadline was almost over. When she told me you were going, I got really excited*".

Katsuki stared at him.

"*That's a bummer, I guess*", Izuku shrugged again, resigned. *"But you're not even going to watch?*"

Katsuki scoffed.

"*Why would I go there to watch?*"

"*I don't know. I thought you were friends with Jirou-san, and the guys from the band*".

"*Yeah, so?*"

Izuku stared at him with a curious look, tilting his head a bit to the side. Katsuki clicked his tongue.

"*Tch. Just because I'm friends with them doesn't mean I need to go everywhere they go. I don't like crowds, and I've got better shit to do*".

Izuku chuckled softly, raising his eyebrows.

"*Like what?*"

"*None of your fucking business*".

Izuku shrugged, a soft smile still painting his lips.

"*Well… I'm sure they'll have trouble finding another drummer*".

"*Did Ears pay you to convince me or some shit?*"

"*What?*"

Katsuki sighed, rolling his eyes.

"*Nothing, never mind*".

Izuku gave him a confused smile, but let it drop.

"*Well, I suppose I'll miss you*".

"*Stop talking as if you're going to this shit*".

"*Well… I am going"*

Katsuki stared at him.

"What for?"

Izuku frowned.

"*Supporting my friends. Hanging out. Just having a good time, I guess. Why wouldn't I go?"*

"I didn't know you were up for that kind of shit yet".

Izuku's face fell, his smile being replaced by frustration.

"Kacchan. I might not be up to a proper fight against you just yet, but I'm doing better. A lot better".

"Right".

"I mean it. I know I'm still…", he thought for a bit, "*Bony. And thin. And I'm not doing so great in sparring just yet. But I'm better. I really am".*

"You're wrong".

Izuku stared at him as if he had slapped him, half-hurt and half-confused.

"*You're doing good in sparring*", Katsuki continued, noticing the look on Izuku's eyes. "*It's not your fault you lost muscular mass. For someone your weight and with your impaired strength, you're doing well. Especially because you literally spent a whole month with no soul inside your shitty body".*

Izuku chuckled, the hurt disappearing from his eyes as fast as it had gotten there. His cheeks grew a bit pinkish, but the pleased wrinkles at the corners of his eyes distracted Katsuki from it.

"*I don't think I'll ever get used to it".*

"To what?"

"You. Complimenting me".

Katsuki sighed and rolled his eyes, a sour expression on his face.

"*Shut the hell up and stop ruining the moment".*

"I mean it!"

"You want me to stop, then?"

Izuku's face fell, taken aback by Katsuki's unexpected abruptness. Izuku had thought he was being harsh as a joke, but it didn't seem to be the case.

"*No. No, I…"*, he hesitated, biting his lower lip. "*I really don't".*

Katsuki scoffed.

"*Then stop making a big deal out of it. It makes me feel weird when you talk about this shit. No one normal makes comments like that".*

“Sorry”.

“Yeah”.

Neither of them moved for a while, the room’s atmosphere becoming strained with tension.

“*You really are doing well, so there’s no reason for me to lie and say you aren’t”* Katsuki added after a while. *“You went through hell, no one expects you to get back to the top so fast. If you were doing terrible, you know damn well I wouldn’t hesitate to tell you”.*

Izuku chuckled a humorless laugh.

“*I know”.*

“So there”.

“Yeah”.

“What?”

Izuku frowned.

“What’s what?”

“What you got that face on for?”

“What face?”

“Like I rubbed shit under your nose”.

“Yikes. Don’t say things like that, Kacchan”.

“You gonna tell me or what?”

Izuku hesitated.

“*I… I didn’t mean to make you uncomfortable. Sorry for making you feel weird. I was actually trying to compliment you”.*

“By making me self-aware as hell?”, Katsuki raised an eyebrow.

“By showing you that something nice you did made me feel good”, Izuku frowned again, confused.

Katsuki narrowed his eyes.

“*But you didn’t say it right”.*

“What?”

Katsuki scoffed.

"You said 'I don't think I'll ever get used to it'. That doesn't make it seem like I did something nice. It just reminds me of all the times I wasn't".

Izuku's eyes widened.

"Oh", he said aloud.

"*Yeah",* Katsuki signed.

"*Will you…"*, Izuku hesitated again, going back to signing. He swallowed dry, embarrassed and hesitant. "*Will you let me rephrase it?"*

"Whatever, nerd", he rolled his eyes.

Izuku took a deep breath, his posture tense, before he raised his hands again to sign.

"I am glad you think I am doing better. And I am glad you spare the time to train with me. I find it hard not to be surprised whenever you compliment me, because I am not used to it, but I really like it when you do and it makes me feel nice. So thank you, Kacchan".

Katsuki stared at him.

Then, he snorted out a laugh.

"*That was fucking cheesy".*

Izuku sighed and threw his head back, rolling his eyes.

"*Why do you have to act like this?",* he groaned.

"I'm just messing with you. It's just I'm not used to this kind of shit, either".

"To what?", Izuku frowned.

"*This whole talking-about-your-feelings thing. I never did it before… Well".*

Izuku studied his face.

"*Do you think the therapy is helping with that?"*

"What?"

"I don't know. The therapy is supposed to help you get in better touch with your feelings, and it kind of forces you to talk about them. So maybe it's – I don't know. Doing something".

A pause.

"*You seem to be getting better at that, that's why I asked",* Izuku clarified.

Katsuki scoffed.

"*You think so?"*

"Yeah. I mean, you've changed a lot. For the best, I mean. I can't remember what happened during the time I was a ghost, but I remember the time after I woke up. You were nicer to me. Kinder. And you were already attending therapy by then".

Katsuki scoffed again, a bit uncomfortable.

"*I mean, you're still… You"*, Izuku continued. "*But different. I like it. And you seem like you're better, too".*

He eyed Izuku, suspicion etched on his face.

"In what sense?"

Izuku thought for a moment.

"We're talking", Izuku shrugged. "*About our issues, about what happened to us and with us, about important stuff. We're not just shouting at each other anymore. There's still some things we need to get better at, but we're… We're…",* he hesitated, swallowing dry but gathering the courage to continue. "*We're friends".*

Katsuki studied his face.

"*You and your shitty labels",* he scoffed, but before Izuku could react, he added: *"But yeah. I guess".*

Izuku sighed, tired. Sometimes, he wished Kacchan wasn't so emotionally constipated.

"Do you feel better?", Izuku asked.

"About what?"

"I don't know. Life in general. Yourself. Your emotions. Do you think the therapy is helping?"

Katsuki pondered for a moment.

"*I suppose. Doctor Matsuo is ok. She's nosy as fuck, but I kind of like her",* he admitted, finding out with surprise that he felt ok saying that aloud.

"*Well, that's kind of her job, Kacchan",* Izuku chuckled silently. "*But I'm glad you think it helps".*

"Why?", Katsuki frowned.

"*I don't know. I worry about you".*

Katsuki huffed.

"*Worry about yourself, nerd. I'm fine".*

“I know you are. Doesn’t mean I can’t worry about you still”.

“Why?”

“That’s just what friends do”.

Katsuki clicked his tongue.

“*I’ll worry about my friends if their guts are falling off their body or if they’re sick or if they have a concussion. Why would I worry if they’re perfectly fine?”*

Izuku tilted his head to the side, a disbelieving look on his face.

“*So you’re telling me you don’t worry about me?”*

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“You know I fucking do, what are you trying to do, humiliate me? But you nearly died like three times and you’re still not fully recovered yet. So it’s only logical I worry. You’re bony as hell and you still can’t fight to save your life”.

Izuku shook his head and looked away.

“*You see, you always do that”.*

“Do what?”

“Get defensive. Except you don’t really get defensive, you get offensive. In the sense that you attack others to defend yourself”.

Katsuki squinted at him.

“Where’s this shit coming from?”

“It’s just something I’ve been thinking for a while”.

“What for?”

Izuku shrugged. He’d been thinking about Kacchan a lot, recently.

“I don’t know. Trying to figure you out, I guess”.

“What a waste of time. There’s nothing to figure out”.

“I think there is. Especially because I have a one-month-long gap of memory in my brain”.

“So?”

“So I’m sort of trying to fill in the blanks”.

“Like I said, a waste of time. You said it yourself that I’m still the same person, just nicer. In my humble fucking opinion, you should take what you can get and stop overthinking. I’m me, you’re you. That’s all there is to it”.

Izuku stared at him, eyes crinkling at the corners as if he had found Katsuki’s statement humorous.

“See? Defensive”.

“There’s nothing to be defensive about. You’re not making any sense”.

“All right, then”.

A pause.

“*The fuck are you looking so smug for?”*

“I’m not looking smug”.

“Yes, you are. Piece of shit”.

“That’s rude”.

“I know. It was on purpose. Maybe this way you’ll learn how to appreciate whenever I’m not rude and finally realize you’re better off not rubbing it on my face”.

“Fine, Kacchan. I’ll stop mentioning it”.

“Finally”.

Another pause. Longer, this time.

“*I think that’s enough training for today”.*

“Yeah, I think so too”.

From: Bakugou

You still looking for that drummer?

From: Ears

I knew you'd come around ^_^

From: Bakugou

Shut the fuck up. I know what you did.

From: Ears

What did I do? :-0

From: Bakugou

You know.

From: Ears

Do I?

From: Bakugou

That's manipulative and fucked up. Not heroic at all

From: Ears

It's not manipulative. I'm just giving you a little hand ^_^

From: Bakugou

With what exactly?

From: Ears

You know.

From: Bakugou

I have no idea what you're talking about

From: Ears

God, you're so oblivious

From: Ears

When you finally figure it out, I want to be there right beside you to yell "HAH" at your face

From: Bakugou

I really have no idea what in the goddamn hell you are talking about

From: Ears

Are you in or are you out?

From: Bakugou

I'm in. But don't think I won't get back to you for what you did

From: Ears

You mean giving you a little push to go out with your friends and have some fun around the people who care about you instead of letting you isolate yourself in your room for weeks in a row and mope like you've been doing since January? Yeah, sue me for that

From: Bakugou

You think you're so smart, don't you?

From: Ears

You'll thank me later

From: Ears

When you figure it out ^_^

From: Bakugou

Figure what out?

From: Ears

Gotta go now, but I'm glad to know we've got our drummer back. The guys will be so excited!

From: Ears

See you later!

From: Bakugou

Fuck you

From: Deku

Hey, Kacchan

From: Deku

Can I ask you something?

Received at: 21:13

From: Kacchan

What

Read at: 8:02

From: Kacchan

What??

From: Deku

Never mind, it wasn't a big deal :-)

From: Kacchan

Just spit it

From: Deku

Don't worry about it

From: Kacchan

Fuck you

From: Kacchan

If you wanna be pissed at me for not replying on time at least text me at a time you know I'm not asleep

From: Kacchan

Asshole

From: Deku

I'm not pissed, I swear it wasn't a big deal

From: Deku

See you in class?

From: Kacchan

K

When Deku arrived at the classroom, his eyes were red-rimmed, his nose was running, and he looked paler than Katsuki had seen him in a long while.

It took Katsuki a split second of staring at the nerd's miserable form before he decided there was no way in hell Deku was fit to sit through hours of class. He practically launched himself from his seat, cutting Kaminari's ongoing rant off mid-sentence and causing all his friends to turn and stare at the arriving Izuku, who blushed slightly in embarrassment at the unexpected attention.

"You fucking *asshole*", was Katsuki's angry whisper (which was too loud to be defined as such) as he marched towards Deku.

"K-Kacchan –", Izuku tried, discreet, but Katsuki had already crossed the room with firm, pissed-off steps and, before the boy could spit out whatever apology he had made up, Katsuki was grabbing Izuku by the arm and dragging him outside, away from the nosy ears of his friends. He could feel all the eyes in the room glued to them, but didn't care as he stepped out of the classroom and slammed the door behind them, not minding the fact that Aizawa sensei hadn't arrived yet.

"Is that why you texted me yesterday? You're fucking *sick*?", Katsuki asked, angry, placing one hand at the wall beside Izuku's head to keep him from trying to run away. "Is this the *not-a-big-deal* shit you kept from me?"

"Listen, I –", Izuku tried, clearly nervous, and now that Katsuki was standing closer to him, he could see the dark bags beneath Deku's eyes that indicated he had barely slept on the night before.

"You should have told me", Katsuki cut him off again, sounding angry and assertive as a way to hide his concern. "You should have said something. You know damn well you can't hide it when you're sick or you'll end up making yourself worse; you got a death wish or something?", he snapped.

Izuku sighed, frustrated, the breath coming out wet and ragged.

“You couldn’t have done anything”, he replied, resigned, the words sounding rehearsed.

“I *could* have shoved some sense into your shit brain and told you to stay in fucking bed and not over-exert yourself because of one fucking class”, Katsuki bit back.

“That’s one too many classes, Kacchan”, Izuku snapped. “I’ve already lost enough of them – ”

“Better to lose classes than to send yourself back to the medbay, *idiot*”, Katsuki scoffed, shoving a hand against Deku’s forehead in a way that could be described as the opposite of tender. His skin felt overly warm. “Is that what you fucking want? – And great, it looks like you have a fucking fever. Seriously, Deku, what the hell is wrong with you?”, he exclaimed, the anger in his voice barely leaving any space for his concern. That was something Doctor Matsuo would not feel happy about, but Katsuki decided he had greater worries at that moment, his heart racing fast inside his chest in a perfect mixture of anger and worry.

“I – I couldn’t tell if I had a fever”, Izuku swallowed dry, nudging his warm forehead against Katsuki’s cool touch without realizing. “That’s why I texted you. I lost my thermometer”.

“How the hell do you lose a thermometer?”, Katsuki frowned, removing his hand from Deku’s forehead. The boy sighed at the sudden absence, leaning his head back against the wall instead.

“I think I forgot it back home, last time I visited mom”, he shrugged. “But after I texted you, I started feeling a bit better, so I decided not to worry you and, I don’t know, just let the subject drop”.

“If *this* is you feeling better, I’m taking you to the medbay myself”, Katsuki said angrily, removing his other hand from where it had been blocking Deku’s way and grabbing his arm again. He turned as if to walk away, dragging Izuku with him, but Izuku immediately protested, grabbing Katsuki’s own hand with a shaky one and not moving from where he was leaning his back against the wall.

“No, Kacchan, please, don’t tell on me”, he pleaded, eyes widening. Even if he looked tired, his grip on Katsuki’s hand was strong, and those big puppy green eyes of his made something weird twist inside Katsuki’s chest.

Deku sniffed, his nose still running, and fuck if he didn’t look sick as hell.

Katsuki scoffed, pissed off.

The sharp contrast with how healthy Deku had looked on the day prior was disconcerting, to say the least. The sight made Katsuki’s stomach churn – he had thought Deku was getting *better*. Sure, his immune system was still fucked up and he still caught a cold or a bug every now and then, but it had been *months* ever since he last got a fever. He was supposed to be getting exponentially better, not having unexpected relapses. This whole setback in Deku’s apparent recovery was frustrating, to say the least, but Katsuki couldn’t risk allowing it to get any worse – he couldn’t allow Deku’s recovery to suffer from an even greater setback.

“Deku. You look like shit”, he told him seriously, his tone leaving no room for discussion. “I’m not about to let you make yourself worse because you’re a kiss-ass nerd. If you’re that desperate, I can lend you my notes later –“

“*Please*”, Deku interrupted him, his voice sounding firmer than his wobbly knees. The way he said the word – the *word* he said – made Katsuki narrow his eyes as he watched Deku with sharp attention.

Deku swallowed dry, taking a deep breath as if to gather the courage he needed to continue.

“Don’t make me go back to the medbay. I can’t *stand* being in there, not again”, he added, dead serious.

Katsuki studied his face. Deku looked exhausted and sick. The thought of him keeling over and hitting his head on the cold, harsh floor – hell, the thought of an unconscious Deku, a fever-crazed Deku, of Deku staring at him with dead eyes – were enough to force Katsuki into a quick, gut-feeling decision.

He shook his head no with vehemence, which made Deku lower his own in order to hide his trembling lower lip. If anything, he looked almost unhinged in comparison to a few weeks before, and it had been a while ever since Katsuki had seen him so fragile, indisposed, and vulnerable. Actually, so far, it had felt like Deku was putting a special effort into *not* looking vulnerable, even when he clearly was, and *especially* when he was in front of Katsuki. The fact that now Deku was too weak to keep up his façade…

The only conclusion Katsuki could reach was that the fever was burning away Deku’s sense of self-preservation. In all senses, since the idiot had just showed up to class while sick as hell.

As if predicting Katsuki’s argument, Deku continued, as if Katsuki had never shook his head:

“I can’t be in there again. I just want to get better already”, he admitted, head hanging low, and his voice sounded wet and shaky, but not in a wimpy way. In a frustrated way, or even in an angry way – in a way that made Katsuki frown, because he couldn’t quite decipher.

“Deku –“

“And I *can’t*”, Deku continued, voice tight, and yeah, that was definitely angry. Not weak, not wimpy. Tired, but also *angry*. “*Every* time I think I’m finally getting better, I’m finally getting my strength back, I get sick again. I can’t take this anymore. I just want to get *better.* I was doing so well; you saw it yourself”, he sniffed again, a fat tear escaping his eye and rolling down his cheek despite his best efforts.

Katsuki’s frown deepened. Everyone knew Deku was a crybaby, but there was something different about this whole display. Something he couldn’t quite identify.

“Why can’t I just get better? Why can’t I just be strong like you or All Might?”, Izuku sniffed, leaning his head against Katsuki’s shoulder abruptly. Had the gesture showed more vitality and strength, Katsuki would have considered it a headbutt to his shoulder, but from

the limp-y way Deku leaned against him afterwards, he could tell it was just exhaustion. He flinched at the sudden contact, but didn't push the boy away.

"What the hell are you talking about?", he asked, coming off as angry but, in reality, feeling more confused than anything. Izuku sniffed again several times before replying.

"All Might kept being the number one hero, even though he had a literal *hole* on his side", Izuku explained, voice muffled by Katsuki's shirt. "You never let something stupid as a cold or as pain stop you. You always push yourself harder and get back up on your feet, but I can't – I c-can't…", he gasped, shaking his head. "Every time I think I'm finally recovering, something like *this* happens, and I try to *plus ultra* it and keep myself going and I push myself harder and everyone acts – l-like, like this. Like I'm some sort of idiot who doesn't know any better, like I'm doing these things on purpose or for attention. And I'm fed up, Kacchan, I just want to go back to normal", he complained. "I can't take this anymore. I *hate* feeling like this, like I'm – h-helpless".

Katsuki simply stood there, arms flat beside his body and as still as a statue, allowing Deku to lean against him with his head resting between his shoulder and his neck and his fingers clinging tightly to the front of his shirt. He only hoped Deku couldn't hear the way his heart was racing inside his chest. What the *fuck*?

"Deku", he said, forcing his voice to sound calm and collected, even if it still came off as stern and angry. "You spent a whole month with no soul inside your body, another month in a coma, and another in a hospital. Your heart literally stopped. You're not gonna get better overnight".

"It's been *months*", Izuku protested, a bit too sharp to be considered his natural. "And I'm still like this. I should be better by now. I know I should".

"That's just how your body handles things, idiot", Katsuki scoffed. "Don't you remember you used to get sick all the time back when we were brats? There was that one time you even managed to get pneumonia because you kept insisting you were feeling better and lying to your mom about it".

Izuku was silent. He kept leaning on Katsuki in that one-sided hug, whereas Katsuki kept standing there and supporting him without enveloping him in his arms.

"You're a slow healer, Deku. It's just how it is. Stop beating yourself for it, and stop fucking trying to force yourself to get better. You'll only make things worse that way", he scolded.

Izuku breathed shakily, deflating. All anger and frustration seemed to leave his body, leaving room only for disappointment.

"But I'm so tired", he lamented.

"Then rest".

"*No"*, he sniffed, pushing himself the slightest bit away so he could look up to glare into Katsuki's eyes. "I'm tired of being like this. *Weak*. Of needing help all the time, of being

treated like I'm made of porcelain. I just want to feel good again. I – I just want to…", he trailed off.

Katsuki frowned.

"To what?"

Izuku sniffed, looking determined and honest.

"Be strong enough to beat you again".

Katsuki scoffed, a small smirk appearing on his lips.

"I'm not *letting* you win, if that's what you're suggesting".

"No", Izuku said immediately, pushing completely away and breaking their contact in order to stare at Katsuki. "That's not what I'm talking about. Actually, I mean the opposite", he shook his head. "I want to be strong enough to beat you *on my own*".

Katsuki's smirk grew wider.

"In your *dreams*".

Izuku chuckled humorlessly, shaking his head with a serious look.

"I'm serious, Kacchan".

"I know you are", Katsuki scoffed. "But you ain't gonna beat me anytime soon if you keep pulling this sort of shit up", he gestured at Izuku. "If you feel sick, take your damn meds and rest. That's the only way you'll get better, any idiot knows that. If you keep trying so hard to be better – if you keep *acting* like you're better, even though you aren't, you'll only make yourself worse, like with the fucking pneumonia. Nothing comes from just wishing for shit, Deku", he scoffed.

Izuku swallowed dry.

"So fucking what if All Might has a hole on his side? He never spent a whole-ass month without a soul. Hell knows I didn't. But *you* did, and no one expects you to act like it never happened. And I can't fucking believe you're forcing me to be the supportive, reasonable one in this conversation, but *everyone* knows what you went through. No one wants you to act like you're ok if you aren't".

"But I can't keep falling behind", Izuku protested, stubborn. "I can't keep skipping classes –"

"You know damn well every single bastard inside that room is willing to lend you their notes if you have to take a sick day", Katsuki cut him off.

Then, something clicked in his brain. He narrowed his eyes, and Izuku noticed it.

"This is not what this is about, is it?", he asked, suspicious.

Izuku lowered his head, and Katsuki couldn't be sure whether the blush that tinged his cheeks was from embarrassment or from his fever.

"I didn't want…", he trailed off. Katsuki sighed and grabbed his arm, squeezing it.

"Didn't want *what*?"

"I just… I…"

"*Spit* it, Deku", he said harshly. Deku sighed, defeated.

"I didn't want to miss more classes. I mean, that's the main reason. But… But the, uh. The spring festival's tomorrow", he admitted, not meeting Katsuki's eyes. "And I didn't want to miss it, either".

Katsuki stared at him.

A beat.

"Is *that* it?"

"Kacchan –"

"Un-fucking-believable, Deku", he scoffed, shaking his head and letting go of Izuku's arm. "*Seriously*?"

"I don't want to miss it!", Izuku said, defensive. His cheeks were flushed and his eyes were watery, but he looked serious – albeit a little ridiculous, in Katsuki's opinion. "And when I texted you to ask about the thermometer I wasn't thinking straight, but then I thought better about it and I realized you and the guys would try to talk me out of going if you knew I had a fever, and I *really* was feeling a lot better this morning, Kacchan, I *swear* I was, I wouldn't lie about it –"

"Yes, you fucking would –"

"– and I don't know why I started feeling bad again all of a sudden, maybe it's allergies making my already compromise immune system even *more* compromised, because we're in spring, after all, I don't know, but I decided not to tell you anything because –"

"Because you're an idiot –"

"No, because I can be strong, too, even if I'm feeling a bit sick!"

Katsuki gave him a no-bullshit look.

"You're leaning on me for support", he pointed out, angry.

Izuku stared down at where his hand was leaning against Katsuki, and he couldn't even remember having done that in the first place. He started to pull back once again, feeling stupid, only to be cut off by Katsuki's angry bark of:

“If you let go, you’ll topple over, and – *fuck,* Deku, I wasn’t telling you to let go, you idiot”, he scolded when Izuku stepped back all the same, grabbing one of the nerd’s arms before he could lose balance and offering him support once more by holding both hands to his waist. “*Stop* trying so fucking hard”, he reprimanded, tightening his grip on Izuku’s waist as if to emphasize his words.

“I’m sorry”, Izuku sniffed again, embarrassed and frustrated. “I really am. I just want to get better”.

“Then go back to your damn room and *rest*. Sitting in class for hours will only make you feel worse”, Katsuki said.

“But I can’t skip class, either”, Izuku protested, looking up at Katsuki with a look that was desperate for him to understand. “I can’t choose the festival over it. If I don’t go to class, then I can’t go to the festival, otherwise everyone will say ‘why were you at the festival but not at class?’, and they’ll think I’m slacking off, and Aizawa sensei will be disappointed in me…”, he rambled feverishly.

Katsuki scoffed in disbelief.

“Are you even listening to yourself, you fucking *idiot* –“

“Why aren’t you two on your seats?”, Aizawa sensei interrupted them, and both boys turned their heads in perfect synchrony to stare at the teacher, who had suddenly materialized at the hallway and was glaring at them with disapproval.

Izuku opened his mouth to speak – probably to offer an apology and a shitty excuse, and *certainly* to affirm that he would return to the classroom immediately –, but Katsuki was faster than him.

“Deku’s feeling sick and has a fever. I was telling him to get the hell out of here before he makes himself worse”, he announced, serious, giving his teacher a look that indicated he wasn’t joking around.

He could feel Deku turning his head to glare daggers of betrayal at him, but couldn’t care less. Deku’s health came first; his petty anger could come second. Aizawa sensei stared at the two of them, studying their faces with sharp attention, before deciding Katsuki was speaking the truth and nodding at him.

“You’re still recovering, Midoriya. Go back to your room and rest until you’re better. I’ll schedule you a replacement lecture, but make sure to borrow your friends’ notes so you’re prepared for it”, he announced shortly, his tone making clear that should anyone try to argue his decision, there would be hell to pay. “Can you walk back on your own?”

“Yes”, Izuku said a bit too sharply and with no hesitation, at the same time Katsuki said “No”.

Aizawa sensei studied Izuku for a pensive moment before turning to look at Katsuki, who was still supporting a bit of the boy’s weight. Izuku, noticing this, tried to pull himself away

from Katsuki again as a way to prove that he could, indeed, walk back on his own, but Katsuki's grip on his arm was unfaltering and he kept the boy in place with little to no effort. Izuku huffed.

"Bakugou, take him back to the dorm", Aizawa sensei instructed, somehow sounding more tired than usual, as if he couldn't quite believe the stunt Izuku was trying to pull. "Take your time helping him, but be back when you're done. I trust you two will be mature enough not to get in a fight while you're at it", he added, pointing a pensive look at Katsuki's hand gripping Izuku's waist like a lifeline. "Midoriya, if you don't feel better by curfew, go see Recovery Girl", he concluded.

And with that, he walked past them and entered the classroom without offering them a spare look. The two boys were silent for a moment as the door closed behind Aizawa sensei and they took in their teacher's instructions.

Izuku lowered his head in defeat. Katsuki removed his hand from Izuku's waist and grabbed his arm instead, as if urging him.

"You heard him. Get your ass moving".

"You said you wouldn't tell on me".

"I never said that. Plus, this doesn't count as telling on you, so cut off the fucking whining. I was just preventing your dumb ass from getting yourself killed. You're welcome, by the way; now let's fucking go".

Izuku sighed in discontent and let his shoulders slump, but did as he was told. He shrugged away from Katsuki's hand holding him as if to preserve some of his dignity, but Katsuki grabbed him again and made sure to keep a hand on him as they walked, almost looking like a guard who was escorting a prisoner.

"You're exaggerating", Izuku moped.

"Sure".

"I wouldn't get myself killed just for watching a single class, Kacchan".

"I'm not about to take my chances with you, since you have proven twice over that you're a fucking moron".

"Stop it".

"I'll stop calling you a moron when you stop acting like one".

Silence.

"I can't believe you did that", Izuku whined grievously after a while. Katsuki scoffed.

"Tch. I could tell you the same. Every time I think your self-preservation instincts are finally kicking in, you go and pull some shit like this".

“Sorry if I hate feeling sick and helpless all the time”.

“Yeah, and pushing yourself to your limit will *totally* make you get better, and so will hating your illness. Do you have shit for brains?”

“Stop it”.

“I’m serious”.

“You’re just being mean”.

“You don’t get a free pass from the truth just because you’re sick, and especially *not* after you rubbed your germs all over me”.

Izuku blushed again, caught off guard by the accusation.

“I’m sorry”, he said, sad. “I didn’t mean to”.

“Deku”, Katsuki sighed. “Learn how to take a joke, for fuck’s sake”.

A pause.

“But you’re not contagious, are you? I mean, you did get sick pretty fast”.

Izuku sighed.

“I’m not contagious, Kacchan”.

“You better not be”.

By the time they arrived at the dorm, Katsuki was supporting half of Deku’s weight, which alone indicated how bad and tired the boy must have been feeling, no matter how many masks he put. He flopped down on his bed as soon as he was close enough to it, curling on his side and sighing miserably. His green curls had overgrown again, and they were now covering part of his closed eyes, the edges brushing against his pink cheek.

Katsuki rolled his eyes at the sight, but there was no annoyance in the gesture. If Deku was giving in so easily – if he was allowing himself to fall apart in front of Katsuki right after admitting how much he hated feeling weak and helpless –, then he must have been feeling *really* bad.

“Get your uniform off and change into something else. I’ll go grab the damn thermometer”, Katsuki announced, spinning on his heels and leaving the room without a second thought.

It took him no longer than two minutes to go to his floor, grab the thermometer, and go back to Deku’s room, but when he entered it again the boy was still in the same position on the bed, lying on his side, knees up to his belly, school uniform still on, and eyes closed.

Katsuki sighed. This time, there was a *little* annoyance in the gesture.

“Deku, I’m not your fucking babysitter”, he scoffed. “If you pull this childish crap up, I’m taking you to Recovery Girl”.

Izuku was silent, lying too still on the bed. For a second, Katsuki wondered if he had fallen asleep.

“Your bedside manner sucks”, Izuku eventually mumbled, burying his face in his pillow. Now that he was lying in a horizontal position, it looked like all the energy he had managed to muster had decided to seep out of him and leave his body.

“I never said I had one. Sit the hell up and take your shirt off so I can take your temp”, Katsuki ordered, his tone leaving no place for denial or discussions. If he purposefully put an effort into sounding harsher than necessary just to prove he *didn’t*, in fact, have a bedside manner, he wouldn’t admit it.

Izuku sighed tiredly but did as he was told, leaning his weight on tired, shaky arms and sitting up on the bed. Sickness apparently made him unusually compliant – not that Katsuki was complaining –, even if he had acted very stubborn just a few minutes before. It also seemed to make him extra clingy and dramatic – again, not that Katsuki was complaining.

(Ok, maybe he was complaining internally, just a bit. What was it with Deku and personal contact anyway?)

Izuku unfastened his tie and removed it before taking his shirt off, revealing a thin, pale torso that was decorated with freckles which matched the ones on his cheeks. Katsuki couldn’t help but to notice that Deku was starting to get some of his muscle mass back, even if it was definitely still a work in progress – while he was still very thin, his stomach was already regaining some of its previous shape, as well as his arms.

Izuku stared up at Katsuki with curious eyes and only then did he realize he had been staring at Deku’s shirtless form for *way* too long.

“Here”, he said, a bit too aggressively as if to make up for his embarrassment, shoving the thermometer at Izuku as if it was no big deal. “Put it under your armpit after you get your shitty clothes off. I’ll wait outside”.

“What? Why?”, Izuku frowned, confused.

“You want me to hang around while you take your pants off, nerd?”, Katsuki immediately barked, way harsher than necessary. Izuku blushed even harder, looking away.

“Oh. Right. Y-Yeah, no, all right”.

“And I’m not helping you out of your damn pants, either”, Katsuki announced bitterly, turning his back to the boy and heading to the door.

“I’m not asking you to”, Izuku said, a bit too defensive.

“Good. Because I’m not doing it. You do it yourself”.

“Yeah, I know. A-And I will”.

“I’m not your damn babysitter”.

“You’ve said that already”.

“Let me know when you’re done”.

“O-Ok”.

Katsuki stepped out of the bedroom, and as he turned to close the door behind him, he caught a glimpse of Deku: he had his back turned to him, and he was holding a stray shirt he had found in his hands, ready to put it on. The scar of the villain’s attack was still there, a bit faded but still contrasting starkly with the light skin of his back, and Katsuki vaguely wondered what would happened if he touched it, if he ran his fingers across it. Would Deku remember everything, like Katsuki himself did back when he couldn’t remember the attack? Would Deku feel pain? Would *he*?

Katsuki felt the tips of his fingers tingle with desire to touch Deku’s back, but instead he closed the door of the bedroom and waited outside with his arms crossed above his chest. What was he supposed to do anyway? March back in, poke Deku on the back and walk out again? That would be ridiculous – and hard to justify.

And yet, he couldn’t quite bring himself to stop thinking about it.

The dorm building was unnaturally quiet, probably due to the fact that all its residents were in Aizawa sensei’s class. Katsuki couldn’t say he didn’t enjoy the unusual silence and peace of the dorm, but he would have definitely enjoyed it more had he been there under different circumstances.

Seconds seemed to last years, and minutes seemed to last decades, and as he heard the faint, distant sound of the birds chirping outside with his good ear, all he could bring himself to think about was Deku’s torso and Deku’s back. He *had* looked stronger and healthier these past weeks, even if, rationally, Katsuki knew the nerd was still recovering and still a bit fucked up from everything that had happened. But maybe that was good, right? Maybe the fact that Deku looked in shape and a bit more muscle-y was an indicator that, this time, his recovery from whatever bug he had caught would be faster and easier. Maybe this stupid fever and this stupid sickness weren’t even that much of a big deal, maybe they would go away as quickly as they came. Maybe Katsuki had overreacted when he saw Deku arriving at the classroom. And maybe his training sessions with Deku were actually making an effect, since his stomach looked like – *that*.

And ok, it was definitely weird that he was thinking about *Deku’s stomach* as he stood outside the nerd’s room, waiting for Deku to let him know when he’d be able to go back inside. It was weird he was even there at all, right? He had come to terms with the fact that he cared about Deku now, but skipping classes because of him – putting his hero career at stake because of him, *again* – was a bit too much. He was missing Aizawa sensei’s lecture because he had brought Deku back to the dorm – something *any* of his other shitty friends could have done –, and now he was what? Too busy thinking about the fact that Deku was probably

naked just a wall away from him? And – fuck, ok, enough is enough. He wasn't about to let his mind wander to *naked Deku* of all places. What the fuck?

"God, what's taking you so fucking *long*?", Katsuki groaned as loudly as he could after two minutes that felt like ten years passed, throwing his head back against the wall and huffing out an impatient breath.

"I'm almost done!", Izuku cried from inside the room, voice muffled by the closed door.

"The fuck are you doing in there anyway? Just put some damn pajama pants on and be done with it, it's not a big deal!", Katsuki retorted, annoyed.

"All right, come in!", Izuku announced, and Katsuki wasted no time in practically shoving the door open and marching back inside, doing his best not to think about torsos and backs and muscles and bare skin.

Izuku was back to lying in bed, already tucked into one of his (apparently many) All Might themed bedwears. He glanced shyly at Katsuki as the boy marched towards his bed with an expression that was as angry as ever.

"Where's the gala outfit, Deku? I thought I'd find you in those from the *eternity* it took you to get fucking changed", he scoffed.

"I didn't even take that long, Kacchan", Izuku squinted, annoyed.

"*Yes*, you did. Who the fuck takes two whole minutes to kick their pants off? Weirdo", he sat at the edge of Deku's bed, reaching for the thermometer beneath his armpit unceremoniously.

"I didn't want to lose balance and fall or knock the thermometer off. Sorry for being careful, I guess", Izuku sighed, bitter and clearly grumpy from being ill, burying himself a little bit deeper into his covers but leaving enough room for Katsuki to retrieve the thermometer. Katsuki checked on his temperature at the same time he absentmindedly pulled the covers back up to Deku's chin with his spare hand.

"Don't get fucking sassy with me. 37,8. It's not good, but not as bad as I was thinking, either. You'll probably be fine if you rest and have some aspirin. And maybe fucking *say so* next time you're feeling sick", he pointed Deku with an angry glare.

Izuku returned it with a glare of his own, though it didn't look anywhere near as menacing as he intended – if anything, it was indignant, especially from the way his eyes were the only visible part of his face from beneath his covers.

"Why? So you can keep yelling at me?", he asked, feeling brave. Katsuki scoffed in surprise at the audacity.

"So I can shove some sense into your shit-brain", he retorted, confident. "Stop acting like a fucking baby. It's not like I don't *always* yell at you".

"I'm not acting like a baby", Deku protested, pulling the covers even closer to himself.

“Sure. Hiding that you’re sick and now acting all snappy because I called you on your bullshit is a total mature move”.

“Maybe I didn’t tell you because I didn’t want to make you so worried!”

Katsuki scowled at him.

“*Haah*? Who the fuck says I’m worried?”

“You don’t have to say so. I can tell”.

“You think *way* too much of yourself, shitty nerd”.

“You said it yourself, that you care about me now”.

“Doesn’t mean I’m fucking worried about a shitty-ass fever that will be gone in a few hours”, Katsuki lied. “And stop fucking shoving it on my face. While you’re at it, *also* stop acting like this is about me when we both know damn well it’s about you wanting to drag your sick ass to the festival tomorrow for whichever reason”.

Izuku had the decency to not reply, avoiding Katsuki’s eyes but still bearing an angry expression.

“Got nothing to say, huh?”, Katsuki mocked. “Good to know you’ve finally decided to shut the hell up and do as you’re told for once”.

Izuku scoffed, but remained silent. Katsuki walked over to the nerd’s studying desk and grabbed the bottle of water and the box of medicines sitting there. He took an aspirin and handed it over to Deku, offering him the water bottle.

Deku stared at him with suspicious, red-rimmed eyes from beneath his covers.

“What? I’m not feeding you this shit”, Katsuki said, shoving the pill and the bottle at him harshly. Izuku untangled his arms from his covers and grabbed them, swallowing the pill and taking a sip of water to help it down. He handed the bottle back to Katsuki and lied back down, tucking himself in again.

“Thanks”, was his short response. He didn’t look at Katsuki.

“Not a big deal. Now go the fuck to sleep, I’ll stop by to check on you later and drag you to the old woman if you’re not better”, he announced.

“Fine”, Izuku responded shortly.

Katsuki placed the bottle and the medicine back on Deku’s studying desk and turned to stare at his curled-up form on the bed, something about the utter bitterness in Deku’s tone making him feel annoyed.

“What?”

“Hm?”, Izuku asked shortly, coldly.

“You can’t be really mad at me for telling Aizawa sensei. You’re not *that* stupid, are you?”, he frowned.

Izuku rolled his eyes and sighed tiredly, not responding.

“Holy shit. You *are* that stupid”.

“Just leave it, Kacchan”, he said, closing his eyes as if to indicate he was trying to get some sleep.

“Nah. Usually I wouldn’t give a *shit* about this, trust me, but I just can’t fucking believe you think you’re in the right and I’m in the wrong here”, he scoffed, taking a step closer to the bed.

“Sure, because you’re never wrong”, Izuku said tiredly and in a monotone.

Katsuki squinted at him.

“Where the *hell* is this coming from?”

“I told you to just leave it”.

Katsuki scoffed.

“You know what? *Fine*”, he made a vague gesture with his hands. “See if I fucking care. I don’t even know what’s the big deal about this shitty festival anyway”, he said, turning on his heels again.

“You wouldn’t understand”.

He looked back at Izuku, suspicion etched on his face.

“Why the hell not?”

Izuku shrugged, the covers still covering his face all the way up to the bridge of his nose.

“Never mind, Kacchan”.

“No, go the fuck ahead. What makes you so smart and me so dumb that I won’t understand?”, he asked bitterly.

Izuku closed his eyes again, sighing.

“This isn’t about your ego, or you, or being smart. And I’ve already told you about it”.

“What?”

He sighed again, louder this time, reopening his eyes and staring at Katsuki with an unreadable expression.

“I’m tired of not being able to do things or go places”, he explained tiredly. “*And* of feeling so sick all the time. I just wanted to go out for once and have a bit of fun with my friends, I just wanted to be there for…”, he trailed off, frustrated. “And now there’s a chance I won’t be able to do it because of a stupid allergy or something”, he concluded.

Katsuki sat at the edge of Deku’s bed again, but there was still a considerable gap between them. He leaned in closer to the sick boy in order to make sure he saw the serious no-bullshit expression on his face as he spoke.

“Stop being such an idiot”, Katsuki said sternly. “It’s better for you to miss the shitty festival and get better than to force yourself to go and come down with something worse. This shit happens every year; you can go in the next one. It’s not a big deal”.

Izuku stared at him with disbelief etched all over his face.

“Of course it is”.

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“Deku, have you even *been* to one of those things? It’s only about flowers and stupid songs and buying shit you don’t need just because it’s cheap and colorful –“

“But it’s your –“, he cut himself off, swallowing dry. “You’ll be *playing* tomorrow”.

Katsuki stared at him. Izuku looked away in embarrassment.

“I didn’t want to miss it”, he concluded, shrugging. Katsuki continued to stare at him.

A few seconds passed.

A snort.

“Are you kidding me?”

“No”, Izuku retorted immediately, a little offended.

“It’s just a stupid amateur cover band playing a bunch of songs. It’s not a big deal. And it’s *definitely* not worth getting sicker for, idiot”, he scolded. There was something warm spreading in Katsuki’s chest now that he knew the reason behind Deku’s insistence, but he mistook the hotness for anger.

Izuku turned his head slightly to glare at him. The way his green hair was sticking unrulily from beneath the covers was verging on similar amounts of cute and ridiculous.

“But I wanted to go see it”.

“Well, too bad for you”, Katsuki answered sharply before he could think about it, immediately regretting the harshness as soon as the words left his mouth if the flash of hurt that crossed Deku’s eyes was anything to go by.

Izuku sighed and turned to lie on his other side, going back to a fetal position and having his back turned away from Katsuki as he pulled the covers up to his ears. Katsuki sighed as well and threw his head back, running a tired hand across his face.

“Look – that’s not what I fucking meant, ok? Well, actually, it is, but it came off wrong. What I mean to say is – stop acting like the world is ending because of one shitty festival. It’s not a big deal. If you feel so bad about missing it, or if you’re really *that* into our shitty music, which I don’t understand, you can stop by to watch our practice one of these days. But I’ll be really fucking pissed if you show up there tomorrow looking like you’re about to faceplant on the floor like you did today because you were too stubborn to listen to me and *stay back here*”.

Izuku didn’t move from his cocoon on the bed, and the only part of his body Katsuki could see was his hair sticking up from beneath the covers.

“What? You’re not gonna say anything?”

Izuku was silent.

“Right. What was that thing you said about not acting like a fucking baby?”

“What do you want me to say, Kacchan?”, Izuku snapped abruptly, lifting his head from the covers to reveal a face that was flushed and upset. “I feel sick and terrible and weak and I’m disappointed I can’t do the things I want to do. I’m disappointed I don’t even have the strength to *go to class,* let alone watch you play. What, exactly, do you want me to tell you?”

Katsuki stared at him, taken aback by the unexpected breakdown. An angry Deku was an unusual sight, and it reminded him too much of that time when they used to share his anger.

(It kind of ached, but he didn’t say anything. Plus, back then, it had been Katsuki’s anger Deku felt – now, it was entirely his own.)

“Do you want me to say that you’re right and I’m too sick to go? Thanks, but I already know that. Trust me, I’m *well* aware I’m sick. And I can’t even complain about it without having you scold me and act like I’m in the wrong for feeling frustrated”.

“I never said that”, Katsuki protested, frowning.

“But you acted like it!”, Deku protested.

“What the fuck is that supposed to mean?”

“You’re the one who keeps acting like I’m insane for wanting to do something as simple as going out! I know I’m still not fully healed; I know this stupid allergy keeps getting the best of me whenever there’s too much pollen around, but I won’t end up in a hospital bed if I’m a bit under the weather or if I go out for a few hours, Kacchan! And you also kept saying you wouldn’t help me take my pants off and – and repeating you’re not my babysitter, even though I never even asked for your help or for you to bring me back here in the first place!”, he snapped, irritated.

“You didn’t have to ask”, Katsuki tried to say, but before he could get any further, Izuku continued:

“You see? *That’s* the problem!”, he exclaimed, a bit exasperated. “I *never* know what to think when you act like this, because your words don’t match your actions, but what I *do* know is that I feel terrible and tired and all I want is to get better soon. I didn’t ask for you to help me, but you did it anyway and then started acting like I was forcing you to do it, so I’m sorry if I’m not super thankful that you told on me to Aizawa sensei when all I was trying to do was get over this weakness, *or* that you keep acting like I’m supposed to get down on my knees and beg you to help me out of my pants!”

Katsuki stared at him.

Deku’s eyes widened into an expression of pure horror and his face became unbearably red, which he immediately tried to hide beneath his bedsheets.

“T-That is *not* what I m-meant”, he stuttered, mortified, voice muffled by his covers. Katsuki could feel the blood rushing to his own ears, but managed to maintain a nonchalant face. “T-That – That is n-not –“

“I know what you meant”, Katsuki cut him off again, surprisingly stoic but secretly awkward. He just wanted to put an end to the weirdness of the conversation.

Izuku stared at him, eyes still wide and…

Was that fear in them?

“And I understand why you’re angry”, Katsuki continued, looking away from the nervous boy with a serious expression. “But it doesn’t mean you’re not stupid”.

Izuku frowned at him, squinting from where they were barely visible beneath the covers that he had pulled up to his ears once more.

“I’m stupid for not enjoying being sick?”, he asked, confused.

“You’re stupid because you’re you”, Katsuki rolled his eyes, standing up from the bed. “And because you *still* don’t know better than to not take me so seriously all the time. *And* because you think that faceplanting on the floor because you’re too stubborn to ask for help is a better option than, I don’t know, saying you’re incapable of taking your own damn pants off”.

Izuku’s frown deepened.

“I… I don’t understand”, he admitted.

Katsuki glared at him.

“If you had asked, I would have helped”, he clarified. “It’s not like I would actually just say no and watch you struggle like an idiot. You don’t have to beg for anything”.

Izuku’s frown deepened.

“But how am I supposed to know that? How do I know you won’t mock me or tease me or hold it against me forever?”

Katsuki sighed.

“You don’t”, he admitted. “That’s part of being friends with me. I tease people. I mock them. If you’re not up to it, you’d better give up now”.

Izuku studied him in silence as Katsuki grabbed the forgotten thermometer and put it away in its little box, placing it carefully beside the water bottle on Izuku’s nightstand. The idiot definitely needed it more than he did, so Katsuki would leave it there for the time being.

“But…”, Izuku tried again when Katsuki reentered his field of vision, feeling awkward. “I never know. When you’re just teasing and when you actually mean what you say. I don’t think I can really tell. I thought I did, but I keep getting it wrong more than I get it right”.

Katsuki spared him a quick glance, a glance that spoke more than words. *You could tell, before. Now, you just can’t remember*.

“You’ll learn it overtime”, was what he responded instead, shrugging and not looking at Izuku. “It gets intuitive after a while”.

Izuku frowned again, looking away.

“Oh”.

“Look, Deku”, Katsuki sighed, crossing his arms above his chest. “I can be a piece of shit sometimes. I know that. And I don’t think any amount of anger management can change that. I’m short-tempered, I don’t have lots of patience do deal with other people’s bullshit, I call people names. I’ve always been like that. And you know it better than anyone”.

“Yes”, Izuku nodded shortly.

“But I’m also different now. I’m trying really fucking hard to be better, even though I still fail sometimes”, he gestured at the space between himself and Izuku. “God, I feel like we keep having the same conversation over and over again. What I *can* do to be better is try to talk more about what I think and feel, because yelling and cursing doesn’t always send the right message. That’s what I’m trying to do now, but it’s fucking hard to me. And I’m way more used to just screaming than I am to trying and processing my emotions. Just talking about this shit right now is already giving me a headache”, he scoffed. “And you’re *sick*. I can see how that might piss you off, and fuck knows I’d be going out of my damn mind if I was in your position. But there’s nothing I can do to change that. And the only thing *you* can do to change it is taking your damn meds and not pushing yourself too hard when you don’t feel up to it. Other than that… all you can do is wait”.

Izuku sighed, his breath coming out wet and shaky.

“But I’m tired”, he said again.

“I know. You think I’m not?”

Izuku shook his head.

“You don’t know how it is”.

“I don’t”, Katsuki admitted, nodding.

Izuku eyed him curiously. Katsuki shrugged.

“I have no idea how you’re feeling”. *I used to know. I used to feel it.* “But what I *do* know is that it’s not like you’re doing it on purpose”, he continued. “Hell knows you’ve got too much of an inferiority complex to actually let your guard down like this out of your own will. You always were the type of nerd who feels the need to prove you’re strong, even when you’re not”.

Izuku chuckled softly.

“Are you sure it’s me you’re talking about?”

Katsuki narrowed his eyes into a glare.

“What I *am* taking about is that I won’t hold it against you if you actually need help”, he snapped. “I might have done that, in the past. I would have called you weak, and called you names, and made fun of you for being so helpless. It’s possible I would have even stood and laughed while you struggled. But I won’t do it now. And I thought you already knew that”.

Izuku stared at him, an indescribable emotion making his eyes water.

“T-Thank you, Kacchan”, he sniffed, emotional.

“You don’t have to *thank* me for that, Deku”, he scoffed in disbelief. Seriously, why was Deku like that?

“B-But –“, he continued when Katsuki gave indication that he was about to turn and leave. “T-There’s still one thing I don’t get”.

“What is it?”, he snapped again.

Izuku stared at him, biting at his lower lip nervously. He seemed hesitant. After taking a deep breath and shaking his head ever so slightly, he asked:

“Why are you so… *harsh*?”

Katsuki sighed, struggling not to roll his eyes. Oh my god. Were they really going to have this conversation *again*? Couldn’t Katsuki have one single day without a reminder of the memories Deku had lost, of the interactions and conversations and developments he didn’t have a clue about? This felt like his personal hell, having to live through all this touchy-feely shit again, having to face the consequences of an event so long gone almost a whole year after it.

“If you’re not – *bothered”,* Deku continued*,* “if you don’t think I’m helpless or doing this on purpose, if – if you’re not making *fun* of me, then why do you act like this?”

Katsuki squinted.

“Like what?”

“Like you’re mad at me all the time”.

Katsuki sighed again, looking away in something that could have been a mixture of shame and annoyance. He exhaled sharply, giving Izuku a pissed-off look.

“Because that’s who I *am*”.

They stared at each other.

“I’m *this*”, he gestured at himself. “I’ve always been this. And me being better than I was doesn’t mean me turning into a completely different person. I’m an asshole, I can acknowledge that. I’m rude and I’m too honest. I’m harsh, and I’m raw, and I’m wild. I know all that. And I don’t think I can be anything else. What I’m *trying* to be is someone who hurts you less”.

There was not much more that could be said.

Izuku looked emotional, but also tired. He was the first one to break eye contact, dragging one arm towards his face in order to bury his eyes on the crook of it and sighing tiredly.

“Your bedside manner really does suck”, he commented.

“I know. I never said it didn’t”.

Silence.

Katsuki just stood there. Something told him he couldn’t leave Deku on his own just yet.

“I think I’m starting to feel better already”, Izuku admitted after a few moments, his voice monotone.

“Just so you know, lying so you can go to the shitty festival tomorrow will get you nowhere”.

“I’m not lying”, Izuku sighed. “I think the aspirin helped. I just feel drowsy, now”.

“That’s because you’re fucking sick. Just get some sleep, nerd”, he scoffed. “I’ll come by later to see if you’re still boiling in your juices and speaking nonsense”.

“I wasn’t speaking nonsense”, Izuku protested without moving or looking at Katsuki. “And I was hardly boiling in my own juices. My fever wasn’t even that high, you said so yourself”.

“Sure. Try not to knock your head on the nightstand if you need to get up”, Katsuki said, heading to the door.

“Right”, was Izuku’s muffled, half-asleep response.

“And Deku?”, Katsuki said over his shoulder, opening the door.

“Yeah?”

A beat.

“Just text if you need something”.

A small smile appeared at the corner of Izuku’s lips.

“All right. Thanks, Kacchan”.

“Meh”.

Izuku heard the sound of the door closing behind Kacchan.

It took him almost an hour to fall asleep.

By the time Katsuki returned to Izuku’s bedroom, the sun was setting.

He knocked on the door, but received no response. He had spent the entire afternoon checking his phone for new messages, but found none, which meant the boy was probably still asleep.

“Oi, Deku. You awake?”, he asked after knocking on the door again.

No response.

Katsuki smothered down intrusive thoughts of an unconscious Deku fallen to the floor with blood pooling beneath his head from where he had hit it on a clumsy attempt to get up and go to the bathroom. Instead, he knocked on the door again, louder this time.

No response.

“Deku, I’m going in. If you’re doing anything weird, better knock it off now”.

With that, he twisted the doorknob and opened the door, just enough to peek inside.

The room was dark, the only sources of light coming from the thin stream of the hallway's illumination now entering it as Katsuki opened the door, and from the kaleidoscopic streaks of orange that had managed to seep through the small spaces between Deku's window curtains. The sunset outside had made the ceiling of Deku's room look almost like an abstract painting, the smiling figure of All Might hanging from his walls looking vivid in the orange light. The room seemed cozy and comfortable in that low light, not too warm but not too cold, either, giving off a feeling that could only be described as *spring*.

Deku was fast asleep on his bed, lying on his back with his mouth hanging wide open from exhaustion. He was no longer cocooned beneath his covers, since they had managed to tangle themselves between his torso and his legs – which were bare, by the way, since all Deku had on was an old All Might shirt and red underwear. Katsuki felt blood rushing to his ears again as he realized that, all the time he had spoken to Deku earlier that day, the nerd had been stripped down to his underwear without him knowing, thanks to the covers hiding his legs.

Stop thinking about this shit, what the fuck.

He approached the bed, taking a closer look at the sleeping nerd. Deku looked relaxed, the color of his cheeks looked healthier, and the pattern of his breathing seemed fine. His hair was a mess of unruly curls sticking out to all directions, and Katsuki found himself brushing a stray of green away from Deku's closed eyes, taking the opportunity to let his fingers linger on the boy's forehead.

He was no longer feverish, and his temperature seemed fine. Despite that, Katsuki untangled the covers from Deku's legs, very consciously *not* looking at his crotch, and tucked the nerd in up to his waist, trying to preserve his modesty and his now regular temperature.

Izuku's closed eyes flickered and he sighed sleepily, starting to regain consciousness, which caused Katsuki to quickly remove his hand from where it was still resting against his forehead. Before Izuku could wake up on his own and find Katsuki there, watching him in his sleep, Katsuki poked his arm, trying to make it seem that this had been the cause of Deku's awakening in the first place.

"Hey. Nap time is over", he said without really thinking about it, and a gruesome memory from a lifetime before appeared in his mind.

'Hey. Wake up, shitty nerd. Nap time is over'.

No response. Izuku continued to lie very still, body splayed on the top of Katsuki's, pinning him down. His arms were spread limply beside him.

He tried to push the boy away and free himself. Izuku simply rolled limply to the side when Katsuki pushed him, limbs splayed in an unnatural manner on the floor and head lolling uselessly to the side once he was off Katsuki. It was only then that it dawned on him.

Deku's eyes were open.

He shivered, chest tightening at the memory, body automatically entering a fight-or-fly mode. He tried not to think too much about how Deku's eyes had looked dead and his body had felt

limp back on that fatidic day, but now it was too late, the damage was done – and all he could see was dead green eyes staring at nothing, lost to the world, lost to him.

But then, Izuku blinked his glassy eyes open, yawning and staring up at him with sleepy confusion as Katsuki watched with dread on his face.

He's alive. He's not dead. He's ok.

(Katsuki's relief overwhelmed him, but he didn't let it show.)

"Kacchan?", he asked, voice hoarse, sleepy.

Katsuki swallowed dry for a moment, catching his breath. His heart was beating frantically inside his chest.

"Yeah. How're you feeling?"

Izuku pondered for a moment, brain still slow after having slept the afternoon away.

"Better, I guess. Just thirsty", he admitted, rubbing at one of his eyes and yawning again as he forced himself to sit up as best as he could on his bed, leaning heavily on the pillows Katsuki ended up propping up behind him. "What time is it?"

Katsuki scoffed and sat at the edge of the mattress beside Deku, placing the paper bag he was carrying on the bed and fishing out a bottle of cool water from inside it. He handed it over to Izuku without thinking too much about it and continued to fiddle with the contents of the bag.

"Almost curfew. You slept the afternoon away", he said nonchalantly.

"*What*? Oh – Oh no", Izuku groaned as he opened the water bottle. He let his head fall back against the wall in frustration. "Now I won't be able to sleep at night".

"Just take your meds, nerd. They'll make you sleepy enough", Katsuki rolled his eyes.

"Hmm", Izuku groaned as he drank the water. He didn't sound pleased, and sighed once he was done drinking.

"Here", Katsuki said, fishing something from inside the paper bag and then handing it over to Izuku.

"What's this?", Izuku frowned, taking the bag and peeking inside.

"Dinner. I figured you wouldn't feel like going down to the common room, and you need to eat", he said shortly.

Izuku stared at him.

"What?", Katsuki frowned, annoyed. Izuku blinked, and then stared at the bag again.

"N-Nothing. Uh – it's nothing. Thanks, Kacchan", he said, almost shyly. Katsuki scoffed.

“Don’t think too much about it”, he said. “Just eat up”.

An awkward pause.

“You think you’ll need to go see the old woman?”

Izuku shook his head.

“Nah. I’m actually feeling a lot better”, he shrugged. Then, he locked eyes with Katsuki tentatively. “Maybe I’ll even manage –“

“We’re not having this discussion”, Katsuki interrupted him before he could continue. Izuku lowered his head, but nodded as his shoulders slumped in defeat.

“Yeah, ok”.

He grabbed the pot of food Katsuki had brought him and set it on his lap, starting to eat. Katsuki grabbed the pot of food he had brought for himself, adjusted himself on Deku’s bed so that he was sitting cross-legged in front of the boy – in a perfect mimic of how they usually sat during sign language practices –, and started eating as well.

Another awkward silence fell between them as they ate.

“This – This is really good”, Izuku said after a while, awkward.

Katsuki just nodded.

“Did you cook it?”, Izuku attempted at the lack of response.

“What do you think?”, Katsuki raised an eyebrow at him.

Izuku lowered his eyes.

“It’s – It’s good”.

“You’re welcome”.

Izuku looked at him, but didn’t say anything. Katsuki decided he was better off silent as well.

A few more awkward moments passed.

“So, uh, how was your day?”, Izuku asked.

“Normal. Not much happened. I’ll bring you the notes I took later”.

“Oh. All right. Thanks”.

Katsuki shrugged.

More silence. Izuku’s still sluggish-from-sleep mind was unavoidably starting to drift off into anxious thoughts of *what the heck is happening right now why is everything so awkward*

what am I supposed to say as he ate mechanically, when a sudden realization made his eyes widen.

“Kacchan! Don’t you have band practice today?”, he asked, exasperated. Katsuki stared at him.

“Yeah”, he shrugged as if it was not a big deal.

“Why aren’t you there?!”, Izuku frowned.

“Because I’m here”, Katsuki responded simply, gesturing at his food. “Having dinner”.

“But Kacchan! The festival’s tomorrow –“

“I know”.

“You should be practicing!”

“I don’t have to. I already know all the songs we’re going to play”.

“But – But won’t the guys be upset –“

“Deku”.

Izuku stared at him. Katsuki glared.

“W-What?”

“I’m not going to the band practice today”.

“Why not?”, Izuku frowned.

Katsuki took a deep breath.

“You complained my words don’t match my actions, earlier. I may still suck at talking about my feelings, and I may still sound like if I’m permanently pissed off about everything, which is kind of true, and yeah, I may still yell, and be rude, and be harsh, but, for the time being… Just focus on the actions, not on the words”.

Izuku stared at him.

“W-What…?”

Katsuki glared at him, annoyed. Couldn’t the asshole make an effort to see what he was trying to do?

“I’m not going to band practice. I’m staying right here”, Katsuki said emphatically, coming off almost as angry.

Izuku blinked.

“Oh”.

“Yeah”.

“B-But –“

“Stop making it weird”.

Izuku lowered his head.

“Ok”.

Silence.

“Thanks, Kacchan”.

Katsuki went back to eating his food instead of responding.

“I was – Uh”, Izuku tried after a few awkward moments, his eyes downcast. “I was thinking too, you know. About what you said”.

Katsuki stared at him.

“And I need you to know I don’t want you to change”, he added, clearly nervous, his hand fiddling with his hashi instead of using it to eat. He locked eyes with Katsuki. “I don’t want you to be someone else. That wasn’t what I meant at all”.

Katsuki studied his face.

“You wouldn’t be Kacchan if you weren’t like this –“, he swallowed dry, gesturing subtly at Katsuki. “I know. What I wanted to understand is –“, he cut himself off.

Katsuki waited for a moment.

“Just say it”, he urged when Izuku didn’t continue.

Izuku closed his eyes for a brief moment before reopening them.

“It’s hard for me. With the way we grew up, the things you used to say, the way you used to act, the – the way you used to call me quirkless. You – You hated me, back then”, he shrugged. “But now, you still act the same, so how am I supposed to tell the difference? How am I supposed to know you don’t actually hate me anymore? How am I supposed to know if you’re being harsh because you’re just harsh or if you’re being harsh because you’ve gone back to hating me?”

“Deku –“

“And I know”, he cut Katsuki off, not meeting his eyes. “You’re nicer. You are. And you’re friendlier. You ruffle my hair, and you ask me how I’m doing, and you bring me your notes, you practice with me, you give me tips, you bring me dinner”, he gestured at his food with a

nervous smile. “I can’t say I don’t like it. I really do, please don’t get me wrong”, he quickly added, huffing out a nervous breath. “It’s just… I know you’re angry, and I know you’re also working on that, but I don’t expect you *not* to be angry. But with everything, with how you used to be…”

“I get it”, Katsuki said before Deku could continue his rant.

Deku stared at him.

“You do?”

“Yeah”, Katsuki said, feeling suddenly tired and fed up. “I get it. And I get it must be hard for you to tell the difference, but – you learned how to do it”.

Izuku frowned.

“What?”

“Back when you were a ghost. You learned how to tell the difference. When I was joking, and when I was being serious. It took you a while, but after you got it, you could always tell. We had discussions like this a million times”.

Izuku blinked at him, seeming surprised.

“Oh”.

Katsuki set his food aside, leaning in closer to Deku on the bed in a sudden surge of bravery, inspiration, and despair.

“Can I try something?”, he asked, serious eyes fixed on Izuku’s. The nerd’s cheeks got red in an instant, but he nodded briefly, eyes wide in anticipation.

Katsuki leaned in even closer, his hand brushing Deku’s waist and lifting his shirt ever so slightly. Deku immediately yelped, jolting in surprise, and his green eyes widened even more.

“K-K-Kacchan!”, he exclaimed, shocked and as red as a tomato. “What are you doing?!”

Katsuki simply stared at him, his expression focused, serious, and his hand still touching the bare skin of Izuku’s waist. Once the boy settled down enough, he continued to trail his calloused fingers across Deku’s skin, feeling the way goosebumps erupted beneath his touch.

His fingers felt the bump of raised skin that indicated he had found his goal – the scar on Deku’s back.

He locked eyes with the nervous, confused Izuku, his crimson ones sharpening with attention as his fingers traced, ever so gently, the scar crossing his back. Katsuki’s pupils widened in attention and anticipation, searching Deku’s greens for any sign of remembrance, of recognition, of anything – *anything* he could use. Any scrap of memory, any scrap of anything.

Deku continued to stare at him with wide eyes and red cheeks, jaw locked in tension.

Great. So it hadn't worked. Deku hadn't remembered, and he was probably more confused than anything now. With a frustrated sigh, Katsuki lowered his head and removed his hand from under Deku's shirt, leaning back on the bed again.

"Never mind", he said, angry. "It didn't work".

Izuku blinked at him, his face still as red as a tomato.

"W-What didn't w-work?", he asked. Then, before Katsuki could reply, he frowned. "W-Wait. You told me that when you touched my scar back then, when I was a ghost, it made you remember what had happened during the villain's attack".

"Yeah", Katsuki admitted with a grumpy shrug. "But it didn't work now".

Izuku gave him a sad look.

"Kacchan", he said, in a tone that did nothing to improve Katsuki's sour mood. Izuku tilted his head to the side with an expression almost akin to pity – but Katsuki knew it couldn't be pity because the nerd knew better than to try that. Maybe it was sympathy. "I know you want me to remember. I want to remember, too".

"Yeah", he scoffed.

"But I can't just yet. I'm – I'm sorry", he lowered his head. Katsuki groaned and rolled his eyes.

"Stop fucking apologizing. It's not your damn fault; don't victimize yourself over this", he scolded, annoyed. Izuku sighed.

"I wasn't going to", he protested. "But – I get it. It makes me frustrated, too".

Katsuki glared at him.

Izuku offered him a tentative, supportive smile.

"I know things were easier when we could feel each other's feelings", he continued. "I mean – I *don't* know, not yet at least, but I can imagine it. The idea on its own makes it sound like it was easier", he chuckled softly. "But I don't think we'll ever be able to do that anymore. And I also don't think that just remembering everything will make things easy again", he admitted.

Katsuki studied his face.

He hadn't considered that possibility. From the start, he was trusting that Deku would regain his memories, and then, only then, things would go back to normal. Things would get *better* again. He had been counting on it. It was his only rock.

But Deku was right. Regaining his memories was no guarantee that their relationship would get back on tracks. And Katsuki felt like a goddamn idiot for not realizing that sooner – for allowing himself to lose his reason to foolish hope.

“But what I do think”, Izuku continued, probably noticing how the expression on Katsuki’s face was getting sourer with each sentence. “Is that we can find another way”.

“What way, nerd?”, Katsuki scoffed.

“Talking about our feelings”, Izuku shrugged.

“Didn’t I just tell you –“, Katsuki started angrily, but before he could continue, Izuku stopped him.

“I *know*”, Izuku said. “I don’t mean right now. I mean gradually. When you’re more comfortable with the idea. Because – I don’t think we can do this if we don’t talk, Kacchan”, he admitted, serious.

Katsuki stared at him. Izuku lowered his eyes and bit his lower lip.

“I meant what I said. I don’t want you to change”, he shrugged. “But I also need to know what to expect of you”.

He looked up at Katsuki.

“We made an agreement. You can call me whatever you want, except for… Well. Except for ‘quirkless’”, he said the word as if it tasted bitter on his tongue. “But sometimes, I think you’re joking and you’re not; sometimes, I think you’re serious and you’re joking. And we need to find a way to communicate better if we’re actually going to be friends”.

Katsuki narrowed his eyes.

“Or maybe you could just suck it up like everyone else does”, he scoffed.

Izuku sighed and tilted his head to the side.

“I’m not Kirishima-kun, Kacchan. My quirk has nothing to do with resilience”.

Katsuki snorted out a laugh.

“What are you talking about? You’re the one who knows me the longest, and you’ve stuck around. That type of resilience is stronger than Shitty Hair’s quirk”.

Izuku lowered his eyes again, biting his lip.

“Yes”, he admitted. “But you said it yourself that I admitted it made me miserable”.

The smile disappeared from Katsuki’s lips.

Izuku stared up at him again, determination etched in his eyes.

“The easy way would be for me to ‘suck it up’ and just accept everything you say and do without thinking twice about it”, he said, serious. “But since when do you like to have things easy?”

Katsuki glared at him, but the hint of a smirk was painting the corners of his lips.

“What are you proposing, then?”

Izuku took a deep breath.

“Like I said, I don’t expect you to change. And I don’t want you to, either. I lo –“, he cleared his throat. “I, um. Sorry. I – I know you. And the Kacchan I admire is this Kacchan”, he gestured at Katsuki again. “What I’m proposing is that we start communicating more. That we try to understand each other better, now that we don’t have a quirk connecting our emotions. That we…”, he shrugged. “I don’t know. Try to be more honest with one another”.

Katsuki stared at him.

“Like. You were so angry at me when I showed up to class. But you didn’t try to understand why I did so. And don’t say it’s because I’m an idiot”, he pointed a finger at Katsuki as he opened his mouth to say just that.

“Killjoy”, Katsuki muttered.

“I did it because I’m afraid”, Izuku continued. “If something as simple as an allergy takes me down, what kind of hero will I be? And yes –“, he interrupted Katsuki before he could start once more. “I know I’m still recovering. I know it’s not my fault. I should have stayed in bed; I know that too. But I think I was just trying to prove myself. Prove that I’m still worth something, even if I’m sick. Prove I’m still useful”.

“You don’t have to do that”, Katsuki frowned.

“I know. But that’s just how I am. The same way you’re harsh, and rude, and angry”.

Katsuki narrowed his eyes, studying Deku’s face. He found nothing other than honesty there.

Fine. Maybe he could understand the shitty reasons behind Deku’s decision, even if he didn’t agree with them.

“Ok”, he said simply. Izuku smiled.

“See?”

“See what?”

“That wasn’t that hard, was it?”, Izuku raised a suggestive eyebrow at him.

Katsuki rolled his eyes, going back to his dinner.

“Your food’s getting cold, Deku”.

Izuku chuckled, grabbing hold of his hashi again.

“We can try again some other time”.

“I already have a therapist for that”, Katsuki said between one bite and the other.

“Yeah, but talking to her isn’t the same as talking to me”.

“Yeah, because she’s a professional”.

“*And* because you don’t tell me the same things you tell her, so she can figure your feelings out while I can’t”.

Izuku really wished he could figure Kacchan’s feelings out.

“Maybe I don’t want you to”.

Izuku tilted his head.

“Why not?”

Katsuki scoffed.

“I don’t know. Maybe I just don’t feel comfortable making myself that vulnerable”.

Izuku frowned.

“Discussing your feelings doesn’t make you vulnerable”.

“Oh, yeah?”

“Yeah”.

“Tell me yours, then”.

Izuku blushed again.

“I just did”.

“No, you didn’t”.

“I just told you I was afraid”.

“That’s not what I’m talking about”.

“What *are* you talking about?”

Katsuki stared at him.

Izuku blushed. Could it be that Kacchan knew how he felt…?

“Anyway”, he shrugged after a few seconds. “Admitting I don’t like making myself vulnerable counts as talking about my feelings, so we’re even”.

“*Kacchan*”, Izuku groaned, protesting.

“So much for taking things slow, huh?”, Katsuki complained. Izuku sighed, resigned.

“Fine. We can try this again some other time”.

“Sure, Deku. Now stop using your mouth hole for the wrong thing and eat the hell up”, he nodded at Deku’s dinner. “Or I’m telling All Might you’ve stopped following his gross diet”.

Izuku rolled his eyes, but went back to eating anyway.

“You’re mean, Kacchan”.

“That’s my charm”.

From: Ears

If you walk out on us we’re throwing hands at dawn

From: Bakugou

?

From: Ears

You didn’t show up to band practice.

From: Bakugou

I was busy

From: Ears

With what?

From: Bakugou

Doesn’t concern you

From: Ears

I think it does, since you left everyone waiting for you without picking up your phone AND without explaining where you were

From: Bakugou

I’ll be there tomorrow

From: Ears

You better

From: Bakugou

When did you go from being all shy weird and awkward to a brat who talks back to me

From: Ears

Since I realized you’re a jackass

From: Bakugou

You’re getting fucking braver aren’t you

From: Ears

You became a lot less menacing once I realized you’re just as much of an awkward nerd as I am, you’re just better at hiding it

From: Bakugou

The fuck did you say?????

From: Ears

You know I’m right

From: Bakugou

Call me a nerd again and I’ll fucking end you

From: Ears

See you tomorrow

From: Ears

And BE THERE ON TIME

From: Bakugou

Being on time is for nerds

From: Ears

God you make it so easy

“Remind me why I agreed to come with you again?”, Katsuki asked grumpily as he walked side by side with Kaminari, the pair heading for the train station.

“Because it’s better if we go together, since we’re crucial parts of the band!”, Kaminari explained with a smug tone.

“*I’m* a crucial part of the band. You’re just an extra”, Katsuki huffed, hands shoved in his pockets as he walked with a hunched, grumpy posture. Kaminari made an offended face, but nudged at Katsuki with his elbow.

“Come on, *Kacchan*! Lighten up a little!”, he cheered, way too excited for Katsuki’s liking.

“Tch. There’s nothing to lighten up about”, Katsuki scoffed. “It’s just a stupid show at a stupid festival”.

“D’aw”, Kaminari teased. “Are you grumpy because Midoriya won’t be there to watch?”

Kaminari barely managed to dodge Katsuki’s fist aimed at his head. He knew better than to keep up with his teasing after that.

They got inside the train and sat down side by side, though Kaminari was careful not to lean in too close to Katsuki, who looked more pissed off than usual and had crossed his arms above his chest. They rode silently for a while, Katsuki staring off at the distance and Kaminari talking to someone on his phone.

“Kirishima wants to know why you aren’t replying to his texts”, Kaminari commented absentmindedly, not looking at him. Katsuki scoffed.

“’Cause I don’t feel like it”.

Kaminari typed something on his phone, probably replying to Kirishima.

“He asked you to check your texts”, Kaminari said after a few seconds. Katsuki rolled his eyes so hard he almost managed to see his own brain.

“Tell him to mind his own business. What are you, his message boy? Tch”, he scoffed again.

“Uh, now he’s calling”, Kaminari announced. “Hey, man, what’s up?”, he said, picking up the call. “Yeah, he’s with me. We’re on our way. Wait. *Whaaat*?”

That caught Katsuki’s attention. He turned his head to look at Kaminari, who had an almost cartoonish expression of shock on his face. Something about the expression felt off – it was too exaggerated for Katsuki’s liking –, but he didn’t comment as he continued to stare at Kaminari through narrowed eyes and waited for the boy to finish the call.

“Yeah, no, ok. Yeah, I’ll tell him. All right. But we’re already on the train... Oh, ok, see ya”, he said, hanging up and turning to look at Katsuki with an almost apologetic expression.

“What?”, Katsuki frowned.

“Uh, so, apparently they changed the location of the festival”, Kaminari explained. “We can stay on the train, though; we’ll just have to drop off a couple stations farther than planned. Kiri and Mina will meet us halfway there”.

Katsuki sighed, throwing his head back in annoyance. He groaned.

“Fucking *great*. Where will it be, then?”

“I don’t know, man. Kiri and Mina just learned about this; they’ll take us there”.

Katsuki sighed and closed his eyes, leaning his head back on his seat and allowing his mind to drift.

He really fucking hoped Deku had listened to him and stayed the hell back at the dorm, especially because, should he decide to be a little brat and attempt to sneak into the festival without anyone knowing, he’d end up at the wrong location, all by himself, while weak and sick and who knows what else.

Fuck.

That would probably happen.

That would *definitely* happen, if years of knowing Deku had taught him anything.

Katsuki sighed and fished his phone out of his pocket, scrolling past the several missed calls from Kirishima, his mom, and his dad, as well as the dozens of unread messages from them as well, until he found his chat with Deku.

From: Kacchan

Where are you?

The reply came less than a minute later, as if Deku was waiting for his text.

From: Deku

Where do you think I am, Kacchan?

From: Kacchan

Stop getting fucking sassy with me and answer the damn question.

From: Deku

I'm where you asked me to stay at.

From: Kacchan

Good

From: Kacchan

And you better keep your ass there

From: Kacchan

Just learned they changed the festival site. They probably did it a million years ago and these assholes just found out about it now, at the last minute. So don't even bother sneaking out to go after us like I know you were planning to do

From: Deku

Wait, what?

From: Deku

Where is it going to be now?

From: Kacchan

Oh sure. Let me tell you the precise coordinates of the festival so you can carry on with your shitty plan of following us

From: Deku

I won't do that. Even though I'm feeling better. It was just allergies, I think

From: Kacchan

If you're not coming then you don't need to know where it will be

From: Kacchan

Bye

From: Deku

Kacchan

Katsuki closed the chat and locked his phone's screen before Deku could get started with his whining, ignoring the pop up telling him Deku was still typing something. He shoved the phone back in his pocket, and only then did he notice Kaminari staring at him.

"What?", he asked, a bit too sharply, annoyed with the look Kaminari was giving him – as if he had just caught Katsuki red-handed doing something forbidden.

"So you won't answer Kiri but you'll answer Midoriya, huh?", he nudged at Katsuki's arm with his elbow again, suggestively. "Didn't know you played favorites".

"Dunce Face", Katsuki said, closing his eyes and taking a deep breath. "If you value having a head, you'll stop talking now".

"All right, man", Kaminari shrugged, smugness still written all over his face. "If the truth offends you…"

Before Katsuki could even think about decking Kaminari right then and there, the train came to a stop and the doors opened at the station. Kirishima and Mina stepped into their wagon, chatting and giggling. They cheered (way too loudly for Katsuki's liking) once they spotted him and Kaminari sitting side by side, and excitedly walked towards them as the doors closed and the train started moving again.

Katsuki sighed, giving up on the idea of trying to catch a power nap before they reached their destination.

(Apparently, he just couldn't catch a break in train rides anymore.)

"Hey, man!", Kirishima greeted, taking the seat directly beside Katsuki while Mina took the one beside Kaminari. He threw his arm around Katsuki's shoulders in order to pull him into an awkward sideways hug (which Katsuki didn't return, but didn't shrug away from, either) before letting go of him. "How are you?"

"Pissed off and tired", Katsuki groaned with irritated sincerity. "Just want to get this shitshow over with".

“Aw. Don’t talk like that”, Mina reprehended, leaning forwards on her seat beside Kaminari so that she could look at him. “It’s going to be super fun!”

“Just leave him, Mina”, Kirishima chuckled. “You know how he is”.

“I bet he wouldn’t be this grumpy if –“, Mina started, but Kaminari stopped her from continuing by shoving a hand over her mouth.

“Shh, shh, shh. Let’s just be thankful Bakubro decided to come along, right?”, he laughed awkwardly, forcedly, only to lean closer to Mina’s ear and whisper: “I just saved your life, so you’re welcome”.

“You’re a bunch of losers”, Katsuki commented, but the words felt half-hearted even to his own ears.

Soon enough they reached the station they were supposed to get off at. Mina and Kaminari led the way out of the train, talking excitedly as they went, while Kirishima walked behind them and right beside Katsuki, who had shoved his hands into his pockets again and was bearing an angry expression.

“So, uh, dude”, Kirishima tried as they walked into the street, eager to make conversation. “Been talking to your folks recently?”

“No”, Katsuki frowned, squinting in confusion. “The fuck would I talk to them for?”, he gave Kirishima a suspicious glare.

“Nothing, nothing”, Kirishima shrugged. “Just curious. You said they were having some problems with money –“

“I don’t wanna talk about it”, he cut his friend off sharply.

Kirishima nodded in comprehension.

“That’s cool, man. Just wanted to know if everything is ok”.

Katsuki spared the boy a quick glance. Kirishima looked like he sincerely cared about Katsuki’s family’s well-being, which, of course he did. Kirishima was just like that.

He sighed and felt a little bad for being so sharp to him, even if he would never admit it out loud.

“Yeah, it’s fine”, he said, still stern. “They’re turning it around. I helped a bit with cash last Christmas and I also stopped spending so much of their money without thinking, so that helps”.

Kirishima nodded, chuckling softly.

“Well”, he shrugged again. “I’m glad it’s getting better”,

“Hm”.

A pause. They continued to walk for a few moments of comfortable silence, Mina's and Kaminari's talk in front of them serving as white noise along with the sounds of birds, cars and other people on the street, which Katsuki couldn't really hear all that well.

"And what about Midoriya?", Kirishima eventually asked, breaking the silence.

Katsuki glared at him.

"What about him?"

"You guys… You know", he shrugged again, nudging at Katsuki. "You doing ok?"

Katsuki narrowed his eyes.

"The fuck are you asking?"

"Nothing, bro", Kirishima chuckled, raising his hands in front of himself in a defensive stance. "It's just you've been spending a lot of time together. Things finally seem to be getting better between you two, huh?"

He eyed Kirishima with suspicion.

"Kirishima", he said calmly, but warily. "Where are we going?"

Kirishima blinked, face paling. He probably thought Katsuki didn't notice it, but he did.

"W-What?", he asked, offering Katsuki a nervous smile that was supposed to look confused, but came off as fearful.

"This is nowhere near any fucking festival", he gestured at the street they were walking on. "So where are we going?", he asked again, loud enough for Kaminari and Mina to hear him.

The pair of friends stopped talking and exchanged a nervous look, before Mina turned around to give Katsuki an awkward smile and intertwined her arm with Katsuki's, walking side by side with him.

"Don't worry, we're not lost", she smiled, pressing against his arm.

"We're not lost!", Kaminari echoed, taking Kirishima's side.

"We're just taking a shortcut", she added cheerfully.

Katsuki narrowed his eyes in increasing suspicion. Then, he halted in the middle of the street, refusing to keep walking and following them.

"All right", he said, calm, even though his voice sounded angry. "What the hell is going on?"

"We're just going to the festival, man!", Kirishima stepped in, and if Katsuki didn't know him so well, he wouldn't have managed to pick the nervousness in his voice.

“Yeah, and we’re already late, so we better get going –“, Mina tried to urge Katsuki into walking again, pulling at his arm gently.

“You’re all acting weird”, Katsuki commented, unfaltering, shrugging away from Mina’s touch. The girl didn’t allow herself to be defeated, however, and instead of taking his arm again she got behind him and started to push him into moving. Katsuki took a step forward in lack of preparation, but then he planted his feet firmly on the ground and refused to move an inch, steady. He wasn’t going anywhere until he learned what was going on.

What if they’re not them what if they were replaced by villains what if there’s a quirk who makes you look like someone else what if they’re trying to lure me what if they kidnap me again

“No, we’re not”, Kaminari tried to play it cool, taking Katsuki’s arm in Mina’s place and trying to pull him into walking to no avail. Katsuki immediately snapped the hand away, defensive, his breath starting to grow more frantic. “Ouch!”, Kaminari protested, hugging his hand to his chest.

“Dude, you’re just being overly suspicious of everything”, Kirishima tried again, reaching a calming hand to him but never touching him. “Can we get going? People are starting to stare”, he looked around at the street.

“No, I’m only suspicious of weird shit like this”, he insisted, looking around. If everything went to shit, he could blow them up and take a turn left back to the train station. He could also go back the way they came, which would take longer, or haul a cab and pay the driver when he got back to UA.

“There’s nothing to suspect, bro!”, Kirishima said cheerfully, and Katsuki snapped his head to look at him. “We’re almost there –“

“Where the fuck is ‘*there*’?”

“God, you’re so heavy”, Mina groaned from where she was still trying to push Katsuki into walking.

“Just *tell* me, Shitty Hair”, Katsuki scoffed, angry and defensive.

“Bakugou, just chill out for a moment”, Kaminari sighed, groaning as he tried to help Mina – as she pushed, Kaminari pulled. Katsuki relented, just a bit, taking a few steps and allowing the three friends to lead him towards the entrance of a park, before he forced himself to stop again.

“There’s nothing to worry about, man –“, Kirishima added, tapping Katsuki’s shoulder as they walked.

“Y-Yeah, man”, Kaminari panted, voice tight, still pulling Katsuki into moving. “Nothing… to worry… about…”, he groaned through gritted teeth with each step he took, tired from the effort.

“Everything… is… *fine*”, Mina panted as well from behind Katsuki, still pushing the boy’s uncooperative body into moving. He was purposefully making himself heavier just to make things harder for Mina and Kaminari, at least until he got a conclusive response from one of them.

“I want to know why we’re here in the middle of this shitty park, where there’s clearly no fucking festival, or I’m fucking going –“

“Bakugou, just –“, Mina groaned, louder, at the same time Kaminari yelled:

“Look, it’s Jirou! Thank god, Jirou, over here!”, he let go of Katsuki’s arm to wave at the girl, a wide smile spreading on his face. Katsuki turned his head to see a tiny angry Jirou marching towards them, and as she got closer, he spotted the confused, annoyed expression on her face.

“What took you guys so long?”, she asked as she approached them, giving them all a disapproving look. Then, she eyed Katsuki, and the panting, sweating Mina behind him. “Bakugou, why is Mina pushing you?”, she frowned.

“I want to know what the hell is going on”, he barked, glaring at Jirou but also searching her eyes for an answer. What was going on? Why was everyone acting so weird? “There’s no fucking festival around here”, he settled for saying, waiting for an explanation.

She squinted at him with a confused look, before crossing her arms above her chest and glaring at him.

“Yes, there is”, Jirou tilted her head to the side. Then, she surged forwards and grabbed his arm, pulling him into moving way more effectively than Kaminari had and dragged him alongside her. He allowed himself to be led, but the suspicion never left his eyes. “It’s just a bit ahead, you’ll see”.

“In the middle of this shitty park?”, Katsuki scoffed in disbelief, but something about Jirou’s tone made him trust her.

“It’s spring, Nitrobrain. People enjoy coming to parks and staring at the pretty flowers”, Jirou rolled her eyes.

“Tch. *What* people?”, he looked around. There were some people spread at the park, mostly walking or sitting on the grass, but there were definitely *not* enough people to configurate a festival – let alone a spring one.

“Just hurry up. The whole band’s there except for you”, she scolded, purposefully not answering his question. “I thought you’d stood us up and we wouldn’t be able to play, but I knew you wouldn’t do that. Just – let’s go, ok?”, she let go of his arm and picked up her pace, walking in front of him.

Jirou was fast and disappeared into a sharp turn covered by sakura trees and bushes before the four of them. And, by the time Katsuki managed to see where she was going – by the

time he took the turn as well and spotted the small clearing she had just arrived at – two realizations dawned upon him.

1. There really was no fucking festival.
2. Deku was there.

He stopped on his tracks, trying to make sense of what he was seeing.

“What the *fuck*?”, he grimaced, at the same time the entirety of 1-A, as long as Mina, Kaminari, and Kirishima behind him shouted a poorly synchronized chant of “Surprise!”

Katsuki stared at all of them with a blank face, confused.

“Happy birthday, Kacchan!”, Deku was the first to greet him, practically launching himself at him and enveloping him into a tight hug. Katsuki did nothing, allowing himself to be held and continuing to stare at all the people smiling at him with an increasing sense of confusion.

Ok. So not a villain attack or a potential kidnapping. Good. That was good.

“It’s not my birthday”, he said simply, but the protest went overlooked.

Deku let go of him and Kirishima took his place in hugging him, followed by Kaminari, Mina, Sero, and finally Jirou. The other students lingered nearby, offering him taps on the back and the occasional nod, as was Todoroki’s case. He turned to Kirishima, who was the nearest to him at that moment, and repeated:

“Oi, Shitty Hair. It’s not my birthday”.

“Oh, we know”, Mina was the one who answered, leaning against Kirishima and offering Katsuki a wide, taunting smile. “Your birthday is tomorrow”.

“We didn’t want to make it too obvious”, Jirou stepped in. “If we forced you to go to a spring festival on the day of your birthday, you’d easily figure out the surprise”.

He narrowed his eyes at her.

“So this was *your* plan?”

“No”, she shook her head. “It was Mina’s and Kiri’s”.

“But everyone helped!”, Mina raised her hands in a gesture of surrender as Katsuki turned to glare at her. “We can’t take all the credit”.

Katsuki glared at every single one of them, not knowing what to think or what to say, until his eyes found Deku’s.

“You were in this too?”, he asked, narrowing his eyes even further. His group of friends took a step back as if to give them some space to talk, Mina and Jirou sharing a knowing look before they walked back to the rest of their friends.

Deku took a step closer to him, an embarrassed look on his face.

“Ah, well… Someone had to convince you to play on the ‘band’, right?”, he shrugged awkwardly, a nearly-apologetic smile on his face.

“And they thought the best option would be *you*?”, Katsuki scoffed. Izuku gave him a disapproving look that felt half-hearted, but Katsuki simply shook his head, blood boiling with a mixture of betrayal and something else he couldn’t identify. It was all too confusing. He settled for accusing Deku instead of thanking him: “You’re a damn liar”.

“It was only for the surprise, Kacchan!”, Izuku protested, smiling with amusement at Katsuki’s reaction.

“So making me worry about you and take you away from class and bring you shitty dinner was for the surprise, too?”, he snorted, angry. “That’s fucking *cold*, Deku”.

Izuku’s smile died on his lips.

“What? No!”, Izuku frowned, grabbing Katsuki’s forearm as he spun on his heels to walk away. Katsuki tried to pull away from the touch, but Izuku’s grip was firm. “Kacchan”, he said seriously, his tone of voice indicating he was horrified Katsuki would even suggest something like that. “I wasn’t faking that”.

Katsuki turned to glare at him.

“I swear, I wasn’t faking”, he shook his head, face serious and concerned. “I really was sick. I’m feeling better now, but I wasn’t faking yesterday. And I was so upset because – because I thought I’d miss your birthday surprise”, Izuku admitted, lowering his head in embarrassment.

Silence.

“I wasn’t lying to you”, he added after a few moments, letting go of Katsuki’s arm and meeting his eyes again. “I swear. H-Here”, he grabbed Katsuki’s hand and placed it atop his chest, and Katsuki could feel how ragged and wet Deku’s breathing still felt. He did look healthier than he had on the day before, but his face was still a bit pale, now that he was outdoors, and his breathing still felt a bit too labored.

(Katsuki could also feel how fast Deku’s heart was beating, but he didn’t comment on that.)

(Beating. His heart was beating.)

Katsuki narrowed his eyes, removing his hand from Deku’s chest.

“And what the fuck are you doing here?”, Katsuki asked, sharp and concerned. “If you’re still sick, you should have stayed at the dorm like I told you to”.

Izuku threw his head back in annoyance and frustration.

“Kacchan –“

“I mean it, Deku. You shouldn’t be outdoors like this. Especially if it’s fucking allergies – do you really think being surrounded by all these shitty flowers will do any good? You’ll make yourself worse”.

“I *won’t*”, Izuku sighed, giving Katsuki a serious look. “You don’t have to worry so much. I’m ok. I’m feeling better, and I brought my antiallergics with me. *And* there’s no way I would miss your birthday, especially since it’s the first one in forever in which we’re friends”.

Katsuki scoffed, shaking his head. He didn’t look as angry as before, but he still offered Deku a disapproving look.

“You’re an idiot”.

“Don’t be mean”.

“You shouldn’t have come, Deku”.

“Don’t you want me to stay?”

Silence. Katsuki stared at him.

Deku stared back with puppy eyes.

He could see the way their friends were subtly watching their conversation, curious, but they all looked away and pretended to be busy with something else when Katsuki caught their eyes.

Katsuki sighed.

“Since you’re already here”, he shrugged, walking past him.

“Come on, Kacchan”.

“*Fine*”, Katsuki rolled his eyes as he walked, Deku trailing behind him. “You can stay”.

“That’s not what I asked”, Izuku chuckled. “I know I can stay. It’s a public park”.

“Shut up”, Katsuki scoffed. “I just don’t want you to make yourself even sicker and come knocking at my door in the middle of the night searching for a shitty thermometer”, Katsuki said grumpily, pointing Izuku with a warning look.

“Don’t worry, Kacchan. That’s not going to happen”, Izuku chuckled. “Especially because you left the thermometer at my room”.

Katsuki glared at him, not laughing at the shitty joke. Deku looked like he was struggling to hold back his laughter.

“Take your damn medicine if you’re gonna stay”, was all Katsuki bothered to say as they approached their group of friends, who were sitting close to a tree. There was a towel spread

on the grassy floor, two baskets of snacks splayed upon it. Looking around, Katsuki found several more towels with different group of people sitting by it. They had really decided to go for a fucking picnic as his birthday surprise, hadn't they?

His friends cheered excitedly as soon as they spotted him and Deku, Mina gesturing for them to sit down next to her. Katsuki obeyed, and Izuku sat beside him.

"How did you like your surprise, Bakugou-kun?", Uraraka asked cheerfully, holding a handful of strawberries.

"You're a bunch of fake-ass losers", Katsuki responded, rude. He leaned forwards and grabbed a strawberry from her hand without asking, shoving it in his mouth, and Uraraka simply handed him the rest of them, searching the basket next to her for more.

"Ouch", Sero hissed.

"Don't worry, guys", Kirishima chuckled, humorous. "That just means 'I loved the surprise, thank you, Uraraka-san' in Bakugou language".

"He's fluent", Kaminari shrugged, nodding. His comment made a row of chuckles erupt in the circle they had formed on the grass, and no one noticed the melancholic look that appeared on Izuku's face at the words.

"Oh, stop being so grumpy", Mina rolled her eyes at Katsuki. "You're just angry we managed to fool you".

"I don't know what you're talking about", Katsuki scoffed, accepting a glass of soda Sato shoved in his hands casually. "I totally knew something weird was up, even after Ears came along", he nodded at Jirou.

"Yeah, and I totally had you with the 'come on, Bakugou, everyone's waiting and the band needs you!' thing, so I don't know what you're talking about", she raised an eyebrow at him, earning another row of laugh from their friends.

"I had to push him halfway here", Mina admitted, putting on a tired face as she drank from her cup. "All that muscle's got to weight".

"You pushed him for like, ten meters", Kaminari pointed out.

"That's already a lot!", Mina protested. "And it was more than ten meters".

"Fine, twenty meters. That's still not halfway", Kaminari protested, and then he frowned, looking at Yaoyorozu. "… Right?", he added in a smaller voice.

Yaoyorozu offered him a gentle nod followed by a concerned smile.

"I'm just trying to figure out what the hell we're supposed to be doing here", Katsuki gestured at the park surrounding them. There were more people surrounding the small clearing than there had been on the way there – people going for strolls or just enjoying the

pleasant day in general, couples, families, dog owners… All sorts of people Katsuki didn't know, even if the place wasn't exactly crowded.

"We're celebrating your birthday, Mr. Explosion Murder", Mina threw an arm around his shoulders, hugging him again before letting go. "We knew you'd be all angry and pouting if we decided to throw you a proper party, so we decided to make it a surprise! And, unfortunately, we had to make it on the eve of your actual birthday, since you're too smart for your own good and would have probably figured it out if we did it on the 20th".

"You had a stressful year, Bakugou", Todoroki supplied, looking as stoic as always. "We all had".

"It's only right we should celebrate with a picnic!", Uraraka cheered, handing him more strawberries but keeping some for herself. "Right?"

"Ugh", Katsuki grimaced.

"Ah, don't make that face. You're gonna love it", Kirishima said, hugging him just as Mina had a moment before. "It's out in the open, so you won't feel crowded. Everyone can do a lot of different things to have fun here, so we'll be minding our own business while you just –", he gestured at several food baskets on the grassed floor – "chill out and eat. Really, this is *much* better than a party".

Katsuki turned to look at Kirishima. Then, he looked at all of his friends, anger and annoyance dimming in his face and giving place to a look that was more introspective.

"You losers didn't have to go out of your ways to do this", he said, not meeting any of their eyes.

"Aww, Kacchan", Kaminari said, joining Kirishima and hugging Katsuki as well. They were on the verge of making a Bakugou-sandwich, and thus Katsuki was too distracted to notice the weird look that appeared on Deku's face at the use of the nickname. "You deserve the best".

"I know", Katsuki scoffed, smug. "But this is too much work".

"Stop it", Jirou pushed his arm teasingly once his three finally let go of him. "Didn't you learn any manners in anger management?"

"If you're expecting a thank you, you should get your head off the clouds", Katsuki snorted, raising an eyebrow at her. Jirou rolled her eyes.

"I'm definitely not expecting a thank you from you", she admitted, but her tone was friendly and teasing.

"Wait", Katsuki frowned, a sudden realization dawning upon him. "So you made me practice those shitty songs all this time for *nothing*?", he asked, indignant.

"Don't pretend you didn't love it", she scolded. "We all know how much you enjoy hitting those drums as hard as you can".

“You little sneaky –“

“C’mon, man”, Kirishima said, pushing a basket of food towards him. “Why don’t you chill out and have some food, huh? Sato made some spicy chocolate he really wants you to try”.

“I made it extra spicy and, for safety measures, no one else should eat it”, Sato announced, looking serious. Katsuki eyed the basket with curiosity, glaring at his friends surrounding him before peeking inside.

“I can’t believe you tricked me”, Katsuki complained, fiddling with the insides of the basked and pointing Kirishima with a glare. “I mean, you were pretty shitty at it, but *fuck*”.

“I gotta say this was hard, man”, Kirishima chuckled. “You’re too smart for your own good”.

“Yeah”, Kaminari nodded grievously.

“Most of the time”, Mina corrected.

“The fuck?”, Katsuki growled, frowning at her.

“Yeah”, Kaminari laughed, nodding again.

“Easy”, Kirishima held him back before he could attack the pair of friends. “Just eat your spicy chocolate”, he put his hand inside Katsuki’s basket and fished out the sweet, basically shoving it into his mouth. Katsuki chewed it with a glare, and once he was done, he turned to look at Sato.

“Fuck”, he said, nodding seriously with an impressed expression. “I gotta say, this is *good*”.

“Yeah”, Sato simply nodded back, shrugging.

They all engaged in friendly banter for a while, Katsuki putting a special effort into looking grumpy all the while, even though he was secretly pleased by the surprise. He didn’t speak much, even though he was supposed to be the center of attention, leaving that task for his excited friends and focusing on eating the sweets Sato had baked them instead. They *were* pretty good, and Katsuki would have to ask for the recipe on that chocolate with pepper sweet later.

Eventually, Iida showed up to invite Uraraka, Todoroki, and Deku to some sort of game, and Jirou and Yaoyorozu left the circle to chat on a nearby bench not too long after. That left Katsuki alone with Kirishima, Kaminari, Mina, and Sero as the rest of their friends slowly spread across the clearing to “mind their own business”, as Kirishima had put it. The four friends spent a while chatting and joking around, Katsuki being the grumpy, silent one as he usually was, but secretly enjoying the company and feeling, for the first time in a long while, something akin to cherished (not that he’d let it show). It was only when someone in the distance suggested to play some sort of shitty group game Katsuki was finally left alone for a while, since no one dared to force him into participating during his birthday, of all days. He took the opportunity to get back to his feet and stroll away from the group, wanting to take some time for himself and recharge his social batteries.

He really hadn't seen this coming, and for that he couldn't help but to feel a bit stupid. It had been a bit obvious, to be honest – Kaminari's exaggerated expressions, Kirishima asking him weird shit, Mina's crappy excuses and all of them looking way more excited about a shitty festival than she should be… Hadn't he been so blinded by his reluctance of another kidnapping or a villain attack, he would have easily figured out the plan using balance of probability. Even Deku's insistence to go had been an indicator, now that he thought better about it.

But, if he had to be fair with himself, he hadn't even remembered his birthday was on the next day. He had so much on his mind, recently, so many worries and struggles and internalized feelings that it was hard to keep track of things, and his birthday – a date he never put too much effort into celebrating anyway – had been the last of his worries, *especially* when all his friends started acting weird as shit and made him think he was in danger.

He hated parties, so he had to admit at least to himself that he was glad his friends had thrown him a picnic instead. Kirishima was right – this way, he had a lot more space, and he didn't feel so overwhelmed. His friends were there, but they were having fun doing their own thing and not breathing on Katsuki's neck all the damn time. He knew his presence was doomed to be demanded for some stupid activity soon or later, but, for now, he was content to enjoy his little alone time in the middle of the whirlwind that his life had become recently.

That was, until Deku found him in his not-really-hiding spot by a small river nearby and sat down beside him without being invited, leaning his back on the sakura tree right behind them.

Katsuki was silent for a moment, staring at the people strolling at the park in the distance. Deku didn't say anything as he sat by his side, knees pulled to his chest and chin resting on the top of his knees. The weather was pleasant and warm, a cool breeze blowing softly at their hairs every once in a while. The silence between them was comfortable.

An eternity of just the two of them sitting side by side and enjoying each other's company passed.

"You should have stayed back at the dorm", Katsuki said with a ponderous tone after a while, not looking at Deku. His voice was no longer angry or scolding, and his face was serious, but relaxed. He meant no harm by affirming that – in his head, it was a clear way of telling Deku that he worried about him without actually using the words.

It was a while before Izuku answered. They both kept staring ahead, at the people they didn't know moving around on the other side of the small river.

"Saying it like that makes it sound like you don't want me to be here", Izuku commented, no offense or resentment in his tone. He sounded honest, like he was trying to help Katsuki see something he couldn't rather than reprimand him for it. Katsuki sighed, frustrated.

"So we're getting touchy-feely today?", he turned his head to raise an inquiring eyebrow at Izuku. Izuku also turned his head, meeting his eyes.

“No. I’m just saying it. We don’t need to discuss it if you don’t want to”, he shrugged.

Katsuki sighed again before leaning his back on the tree as well.

“It’s not about me wanting you to be here or not. It’s about how you were sick and feverish yesterday, and now you’re here sitting beneath a tree with me. And you don’t even have a coat on”.

Izuku lowered his head.

“I didn’t think there’d be a breeze”.

“I’m pretty sure you didn’t think at all”, Katsuki retorted. Izuku stared at him, and he stared back.

“You don’t have to be so rude all the time, you know”.

Katsuki clicked his tongue.

“I thought you were getting used to it”.

“I was”, Izuku nodded, going back to looking at the people. “And I am. But sometimes…”

He paused.

“What?”

He looked at Katsuki again.

“Sometimes it’s a bit too much”.

Katsuki stared at him. He looked serious, and honest, and open. The breeze was making the curls above his brow move, and the green of his hair and his eyes matched the park they were sitting at perfectly, almost complementary.

Katsuki found himself shocked at the realization that the found Deku looked beautiful like this.

He closed his parted lips, swallowing dry and attempting to regain some of his composure.

“Sometimes”, Deku continued, not having noticed Katsuki’s reaction. He looked away. “Sometimes it’s hard. In a lot of senses”.

He stared at Izuku.

“I told you. If you aren’t up for it…“, he trailed off.

Izuku snapped his head towards him again, his pretty brow scrunching up a bit in a frown.

“Why am I the only one who has to adapt?”

Katsuki narrowed his eyes.

“What?”

“I know we agreed I don’t want you to change, but we also agreed I’m not going to ‘suck it up’ to make things easier on you. But you keep talking as if I’m the only one who needs to do something. As if the only options are me accepting everything you do, or me walking away”.

Katsuki stared.

“Nothing is that binary, Kacchan. There has to be a third option. A – A middle ground we can find, between you being yourself and you…”, he trailed off, shaking his head.

Katsuki wanted to tell him to continue, to finish that thought, but he found himself saying, assertive:

“You think you’re the only one who has to adapt? After all the shit we went through?”

Izuku sighed and bit his lower lip.

“That’s not what I meant”, he said, almost frustrated.

“I sure hope it’s not”, Katsuki snapped. For some reason, this conversation was throwing him back into an angry fit of annoyance. He tried to think of every tip Doctor Matsuo had ever given him to smother his fury down and focus, but the way Deku was looking at him was making it hard. Why did he have to come all the way here just to pick up a fight with him? Couldn’t the nerd have just left him alone for a while instead of trying to force Katsuki into a conversation about their feelings – a conversation he clearly did not want to have at that moment? Or better – couldn’t he make an effort to interpret Katsuki’s worry for what it was, instead of constantly trying to problematize it?

Deku had the audacity to look upset by his response, sitting a bit more upright and giving Katsuki a serious look.

“All I’m trying to say is that you keep telling me that if I want to be friends with you, I need to suck it up and accept the way you treat me, but I’ve already told you I won’t do it when you’re unnecessarily mean. And I won’t give up and leave, either”.

“*Yeah*”.

Izuku scoffed in disbelief, his frown deepening.

“*Yeah*?”

“Yeah”, Katsuki shrugged.

“So you *want* me to give up and leave?”, Izuku tilted his head, offended.

Katsuki scoffed in annoyance.

“Do *you* want to give up and leave?”, he raised another eyebrow at him.

Izuku looked shocked.

“Are you seriously asking me that? After all these years?”

Katsuki looked away, impatient and annoyed and incredibly frustrated.

“I just don’t see how it would hurt you to try and be a little nicer”, he added when Katsuki didn’t respond.

(“He was being nice to you”, Deku pointed out as if it was obvious. “It wouldn’t hurt to be nice back”.

“Yes, it would”, Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“No, Kacchan, it wouldn’t!”, Deku exclaimed with a chuckle, as if Katsuki’s lack of proper manners was extremely endearing to him. “Why don’t you just try it?”)

Katsuki closed his eyes at the memory.

“It would”, he said, the words tasting bitter on his tongue.

I tried being nice and look at where it brought me.

Izuku huffed out a breath.

“I don’t think so. I think you could at least try –“

“Why are you so obsessed with turning me into something I’m not?”, he snapped.

Izuku stared at him, frowning.

“That’s not what I’m trying to do. I’ve already told you I don’t want you to –”

“Spare me”, he cut him off sharply. Deku wanted to have a shitty discussion instead of just hanging the hell out? Katsuki would *give* him a shitty discussion. “I think it fucking *is* what you’re trying to do. I think you’ve idealized me your whole life, you’ve put me in a pedestal of what you think I am, what you think I’m supposed to be, all from the crappy perspective of your far-away perception of me, because we were never actually friends before, so you saw what you wanted to see. And you thought what you wanted to think. And now that you’re really getting to know me, I’m not living up to your demented expectations, and you want me to change to fit them, but guess what? I’m still me, you’re still you, and I’m trying to be better but I won’t mold myself into your personal view of me”.

Izuku’s mouth was agape.

“I’m rude. I’m foul-mouthed. I’m short-tempered. I don’t know how to show people I care about them, so I yell. I’m trying to work on that last part, but it’s not easy”, he looked deep into Izuku’s eyes. “And it’s even harder when you act like you’re ok with it for months, when

you spend months *sucking it up,* and then suddenly change your mind and decide I'm a mean bastard who must hate you, even though I've already told you I don't".

Izuku blushed at this, lowering his head. Katsuki looked away, going back to staring at the passerby.

"What *happened,* Deku?", he asked, bitter, shaking his head slightly. "Why are you suddenly so bothered by me?"

"Nothing", was Izuku's reflex response, which came off way too quick. Katsuki sighed.

"From the way you keep complaining about me every time we hang out, it sounds like you're the one who hates me".

Izuku's eyes widened.

"Kacchan –"

"Listen, Deku –"

"No, fine, ok", Izuku corrected himself before Katsuki could continue. He sounded like he was trying to keep it together – like he was struggling to be calm and rational and comprehensive. "I get it. I really do. I wasn't complaining before, I – I did spend months without complaining, so this must seem out of the blue to you. And you being rude doesn't actually bother me, not really. I've gotten used to it. You've been like this since forever, it's who you are".

Katsuki looked at him.

"It's just… Uh, I don't really know how to say it", it was Izuku's turn to break their eye contact, hugging his knees closer to his chest in embarrassment and facing away from Katsuki. "I didn't plan to say it today, or – or like this, you know", he fiddled with the hem of his shirt.

Katsuki narrowed his eyes.

"Say what?"

Izuku swallowed dry and took a deep breath, turning his head towards Katsuki's but not meeting his eyes. He kept them downward instead.

"You've… W-We've… Well", he chuckled, but there was no humor in the gesture. "We've both changed", he shrugged. "And I can't remember how much I've changed just yet, and I'm pretty sure my memory loss must have caused some setback in that, but, uh, you have. Changed, I mean. A – A lot. And you also have… Uh, you, you know what. My… My quirk. And, I mean, we've known each other for over a decade, and I've always looked up to you, you know that, and – a-and then our s-souls were bonded and now you have One F-For All, and… I mean, what I'm trying to say –"

"Deku", Katsuki interrupted the rant, serious. "Just spit it".

Izuku lowered his head, biting his lower lip.

“What I’m trying to say is that… I… I really like you, Kacchan”, he admitted, blushing.

Katsuki’s eyes narrowed and he frowned.

Izuku stared up at him at his silence, expecting a response.

“Uh…”, he tried when none came.

“I don’t see your point”, Katsuki said, confused, waiting for a conclusion. What did Deku mean, he liked him? Katsuki knew that. Deku had spent years following him and admiring him and praising him – of *course* he liked him. Hell, he didn’t remember it, but he had even admitted he loved him, back when he was a ghost. What did that have to do with anything they were discussing before?

Izuku blushed harder, looking away awkwardly and seeming almost desperate.

“W-Well”, he swallowed dry again, face red. “I know you said you care about me, and that you worry, and I know y-you had to go through terrible things because of m-me, and, and *with* me, you told me about them, but I – I…“, he sighed, shaky. “I don’t… I just don’t know. You know?”

Katsuki squinted, feeling even more confused.

“No”, he shook his head, frowning. “I have no idea what you’re talking about”.

Izuku threw his head back, looking skyward as if begging a silent force for help. Then, he closed his eyes for a brief moment, as if gathering his courage, before meeting Katsuki’s eyes again.

“You say you care. And you worry. And you even like me a bit better now”, he stated, sounding a bit too eager.

Katsuki nodded, attentive.

Izuku stared at him, nodding encouragingly.

Katsuki stared back, blankly. When Izuku didn’t say anything, he shrugged in confusion, indicating for him to continue.

Izuku sighed, frustrated.

“Um… And… Well”, Izuku swallowed dry. “You say that, but, b-but – it’s like I told you yesterday. Your… Your words. They don’t really match your actions”.

“Yeah”, Katsuki nodded, a bit offended. “That was before I skipped the useless band practice to bring you dinner and keep you company”.

“Yes”, Izuku nodded emphatically. “And I really appreciate that. But can you see how confusing that is?”

Katsuki frowned.

“No. I told you to pay attention to the actions, and not the words”.

Izuku sighed in frustration, looking increasingly desperate.

“L-Look”, he said, trying to sound calm. “You’re nice to me. Well, nicer than you used to be. You practice sign language with me, you bring me food sometimes, you talk to me, you ask how I’m doing. That’s nice. I really enjoy it”.

“Ok”, Katsuki frowned.

“But then you act harsh to me, and you call me names – and I’m not bothered by it, I know you’re like that with everyone, but the thing is not you calling me stupid or asshat or that sort of stuff. It’s – It’s when you say stuff that hits… uh… A bit closer to home”.

Katsuki stared at him.

“Like what?”

Izuku took in a sharp breath.

“Like that thing you said about being a weirdo for taking too long to change clothes. Or that other thing about the germs”, he shrugged.

“Those were fucking jokes”, Katsuki retorted, confused. “And I stand by what I said – you need to learn how to take one”.

“That’s my point”, Izuku said. “I’ve told you. I never know when you’re joking. Sometimes, I think you are, and you’re not; sometimes, I think you aren’t, and you are. I just – I can’t tell”.

Katsuki sighed.

“We’ve been over this shit already, Deku –“

“I know what you’re going to say”, he cut Katsuki off before he could even start. “And I’m not trying to force you into talking to me, or into discussing your feelings. I know that there’s a lot I’ll only remember when I get my quirk back. But – I… I don’t know when that will be. Every time I think I’m getting better, I get worse again”.

“Deku –“

“What I’m trying to say is”, he took a sharp breath. “It still hurts a bit. Sometimes”.

Katsuki studied him.

“A-And I’m not – saying this to be mean, or to shove it on your face”, he added quickly. “I’m saying it because you told me you’re trying to be better. So I thought you needed to know. I thought – y-you needed to know how I feel about you”.

Katsuki looked at him with an unreadable expression.

Izuku stared back with expectation.

“I know”.

I used to feel it. His pain, his sorrow, his hurt. I used to know it.

“Y-You do …?”, Izuku stuttered, clearly nervous.

“We used to do this thing, back when you were a ghost”, Katsuki said. Izuku stared at him with attention. “You’d say ‘you’re being an asshole’ every time I was one without realizing”.

Izuku blinked.

“Oh”.

“Yeah. It kind of helped us both”.

“That – Well”, Izuku chuckled, nervous. “That’s… That’s not exactly what I meant, Kacchan”.

Katsuki frowned.

“Then what did you mean?”

Izuku chuckled nervously, looking like he was on the verge of tears, but not in a sad way – in a nervous way.

“Never mind”, he sniffed, waving a dismissive hand at him and looking a bit frustrated. “Are you ok, though? With going back to that?”

“To the saying-I’m-an-asshole thing?”, he frowned.

“Yeah”.

Katsuki shrugged.

“It will help you more than it will help me, so suit yourself”.

Izuku frowned, tilting his head to the side.

“What do you mean?”

“Well”, Katsuki sighed. “You’re the one who lost a month worth of memories. Before you left, we were doing pretty good. You’d already learned how to tell when I was serious or not”.

Izuku stared at him.

“It’s just a matter of getting us back on the same page”, Katsuki concluded. “Getting us back into tune”.

Izuku suddenly narrowed his eyes.

“Wait. You said ‘without realizing’”.

“What?”

“You said I’d tell you were being an asshole when you were being one *without realizing*”.

“I didn’t know you were foul-mouthed too, Deku”, Katsuki raised a teasing eyebrow at him, feeling melancholic and nostalgic. The jest flew over Deku’s head, as he didn’t have the memory to understand the joke.

“Does that mean there are times when you’re mean on purpose?”, Izuku frowned.

“That’s part of my charm”, Katsuki shrugged, a smirk threatening to appear at the corners of his lips. Izuku chuckled, shaking his head.

“Yeah”, he said without thinking too much about it. This was the first time he responded to the phrase.

“What?”, Katsuki frowned, confused. Izuku’s eyes widened slightly in embarrassment when he realized what he had said.

“Hm?”, he asked, voice high-pitched and cheeks pink.

Before Katsuki could answer, a loud explosion resonated from somewhere behind them.

He was lucky Hatsume had made Hearing Aid Version 7.9 for him, otherwise the feedback on his ear would have made him go insane. The explosion had been loud and sudden, sending his heart all the way up to his throat. No air had been dislodged, though, which meant he and Deku were still sitting at the same position, if only a bit hunched over in surprise.

“What was that?!”, Izuku asked, exasperated. He tried to get to his feet, but Katsuki pulled him back down to the floor, heart racing.

If this was a villain – if this was the League –, then he needed to keep Deku as far away from them as possible. But his friends had been back there, way closer to the source of the sound, and Katsuki couldn't simply hide away like a coward with Deku when there were people – people he cared about – that could be in need of help.

Fuck, fuck, fuck, fuck. He needed to *think*. The ringing in his good ear made it hard to focus, and before he knew it Deku was pushing himself to his feet again, ready to run towards the source of the sound – towards the source of the danger.

The faces of his friends were blurry around him, staring at him with concern and with pleas on their voices, but all Katsuki could see and concentrate on was Deku.

Deku, who was on the floor. Deku, who looked horrified. Deku, who looked as if he was just as in much pain as Katsuki.

Deku, who was being dragged across the floor by an invisible rope.

"Deku", Katsuki swallowed dry, breathing hard, attempting to regain his composure as he got to his feet as well and grabbed Deku's arm to stop him. "Stay here".

"What?", Izuku frowned, snapping his head back at Katsuki in confusion. Katsuki was having a hard time catching his breath – why was that happening to him, and why was his heart racing so damn much?! –, but his grip on Deku's arm was unrelenting. "Kacchan, you can't possibly think –"

"I'm not *fucking* joking", Katsuki interrupted him, breathing labored, a serious expression on his face as he glared deep into Izuku's eyes. His tone told Izuku everything he needed to know about how much he had meant those words.

"But I want to help –"

"And you'll help by staying the fuck back here and waiting until someone comes get you", Katsuki interrupted him again, turning on his heels and jogging away. Izuku immediately followed him.

"I'm not sitting around while our friends could be hurt!", he protested, right at Katsuki's heels.

Katsuki turned around abruptly, grabbing both of Izuku's arms in a tight grip.

"You'll fucking stay here. I'll go see what happened. If you try to fucking argue with me, I'll call All Might".

Another explosion resonated nearby, but it wasn't as loud as before. Both boys flinched.

"No way", Izuku shook his head. "You could get hurt".

"Deku", Katsuki barked. "You're sick. You're not in shape. You can't help".

"I can do something; I can aid them –"

“You’re a fucking liability!”, Katsuki shouted, pushing the boy away a bit. Couldn’t the fucking nerd see that he was just trying to keep him safe? Just trying to prevent him from dying?

Deku’s eyes were open. His face was slack, stuck in a ridiculous expression that was a mixture of pain and surprise, lips parted slightly and eyes half-lidded. Beneath the lids, Katsuki found a familiar green which lacked its even more familiar liveliness. No, Deku’s eyes were cold and empty, deprived of its usual spark and emotion.

Deku’s eyes were dead.

Deku’s eyes had been dead.

Deku’s eyes were now determined.

“You’re not doing this”, he shook his head, stubborn. “You’re not talking me out of this by being *rude* –“

“I’m just trying to keep your stupid ass from getting killed –“

“You’re not scaring me away!”, Izuku shouted, angry.

Katsuki pushed at him again, hard, making him lose balance and fall to the floor on his butt.

“I’m not fucking *scaring* you, idiot, I’m trying to save your damn life, which is something you seem to suck at doing on your own”, he shouted back, trying to forget the images of Deku lying dead in an alley, Deku screaming in pain, Deku’s heart stopping, Deku out of his mind with fever and illness. “You’ll stay the fuck here, and I’ll go the fuck back there, and if I see your stupid face around there while I figure out what happened we’re gonna have a *serious* problem. I’m not letting you do this”.

With that, he turned his back on Deku, ready to rush away again.

“Why?”, Deku had the audacity to demand from where he was still fallen on the floor.

Katsuki turned to him, fury in his crimson eyes. Impulse, hot and burning, overwhelmed him, and before he knew better the words had already left his mouth.

“Because right now you’re a quirkless loser, and you’ll end up getting yourself killed again”.

The flash of raw hurt in Deku’s eyes wouldn’t leave Katsuki’s mind anytime soon.

In that moment, he knew he had fucked up big time. He *knew.* But his heart was racing, his lungs weren’t working, his veins were flooded with adrenaline and he needed to help his friends. In all honesty, he’d prefer it if Deku hated him and lived than if Deku loved him and died.

“Bakugou!”, a familiar voice called from behind him. Katsuki spun around without hesitation, finding Jirou rushing towards them.

“Ears”, he said, jogging towards her in order to meet her halfway, subconsciously checking her over for any possible injuries. “What the fuck happened?”, he asked, assertive and angry and anxious.

“Everyone’s fine”, she reassured him right away, panting. “I came to check on you. That noise can’t have been good for your hearing”, she said, getting on the tip of her toes and trying to get a look at his hearing aid. He leaned away from her touch, overwhelmed by everything that was happening all at once.

“What the *hell* was that?”, he demanded, angry and nervous.

“Just a mix-up of a rando and some bad luck”, she explained. “Everything’s fine. This dude who also happens to have a sound quirk was walking by the park. Our quirks’ frequencies didn’t get along too well”.

Katsuki frowned.

“That was *you*?”

“Not just me. Me and him”, she explained, a bit defensive. “You know when you put a microphone too close to the sound box? It was like that, except the feedback was our heartbeats”.

Katsuki stared at her.

“So nothing exploded?”, he asked.

“Nope”.

“And everyone’s fine?”

“Yep. We were just worried about you, because…”, she spared his bad ear another quick glance. “Well. You know”.

The weight of what he had done suddenly seemed a lot heavier, now that he knew there was no incoming danger to justify it.

Apparently reading his mind, Jirou’s eyes finally looked past Katsuki and found the fallen Izuku on the floor, which sent a frown to her face.

“Midoriya? Are you ok?”, she asked, concerned, taking a step towards him. Katsuki turned to face him once again, finding tears running down his flushed cheeks and betrayal etched deep into his hurt eyes.

“I’m f-fine, Jirou-san, thanks”, he said politely, voice thick and heavy with emotion.

“Are you hurt? Why are you –“

“He said he’s fine”, Katsuki cut her off, giving her a warning glare. At this, she turned to study Katsuki’s face for a few moments, suspicion appearing in her eyes.

“What did you do?”, she asked in a low voice, but there was no way Deku didn’t hear it from where he was struggling to get to his wobbly feet.

“I thought we were under attack”, he explained shortly, giving her a look that indicated now wasn’t the best time to discuss that. “I thought it was the League. And he wanted to go there and help”.

Jirou spared Izuku another look, noticing that he had managed to get up on his own, before turning to Katsuki again.

He glared at her, trying to say everything he couldn’t through one look. She narrowed her lips, looking displeased, but also comprehensive.

“I’ll go tell the guys you’re ok”, she announced shortly, seriously. “I’ll also tell them I think it’s time to sing happy birthday and head back to UA”.

Katsuki blinked in surprise.

“Midoriya”, she said, looking deep into Katsuki’s eyes, before she turned to Izuku again, serious. “Are you sure you’re ok?”

Izuku nodded briefly, not able to meet her eyes from the embarrassment and humiliation he was feeling. She nodded back, before locking eyes with Katsuki again.

“Whatever this was, fix it”, she basically whispered before spinning on her heels and marching away as fast as she had arrived.

Katsuki turned to look at Deku, who was no longer looking at him as he tapped away the dirt and the grass from his clothes.

“Deku –“

“Don’t”.

“Can you just –“

“I said *don’t*”.

Katsuki’s blood boiled.

“Stop being a brat and *listen* to me!”, he grabbed one of Izuku’s arms. Izuku slapped it away, cold, dismissive, distant. He started to walk away from Katsuki and towards the clearing, towards his friends.

“I don’t want to listen to anything you have to say”, he said shortly, back turned to Katsuki.

“I didn’t mean it like that. I was just trying to keep you from doing something stupid”, Katsuki barked, trailing after Izuku and easily catching up with him.

“Oh, yeah? Like what?”, Izuku asked, bitter. “Like jumping at a sludge villain who was going to choke you to death even though I had no means to defend you? Like taking a blow that could have killed me to save your life? Like choosing *you* to pass All Might’s legacy to when I thought I was dying, even though all I am to you is a *quirkless loser*?”

Katsuki shook his head.

“You know I don’t see you like that anymore. I fucking told you”.

“Yeah, *Kacchan*, you told me a lot of things. You also told me not to mind your words, but your actions, so *there*. And funny of you to say you don’t ‘see me like that anymore’, when *all* you ever call me is *Deku*, and never my actual name”, he came to an abrupt stop, glaring at Katsuki.

Katsuki glared back at him.

“Go on”, Deku demanded, looking angrier than Katsuki remembered ever seeing him, even back when he was bearing half of his anger. He also looked determined. “Say it”.

“What?”, Katsuki frowned.

“Say my name”.

Katsuki scoffed.

“Stop trying to fucking do this”, he snapped, annoyed. “I didn’t mean it like that and you know it. Fine, it was a dick move, I know, but I needed you to *stand back* and you weren’t stopping”.

“God, you can’t, can you?”, Izuku laughed humorlessly, shaking his head. “You can’t even say it, after all those years. And stand back from *what*?”, Izuku scoffed. “From a guy with a *sound* quirk? You didn’t even know what the threat was and you already deemed me incapable of handling it –“

“Because you *are* incapable!”, Katsuki shouted. “God, what the fuck is wrong with you? Do you actually *have* a death wish?!”

“*No*”, Izuku shouted back, shaking. “I just find it really hard to stand by doing nothing when there are people who could need my help!”, Izuku shook his head.

“And what the hell are you trying to imply with that?”

“I’m implying that I don’t wait until people *beg* in order to make a move!”, Izuku shouted back.

“And when have I fucking done that?!”

“When *haven’t* you?!”

Katsuki stared at him, angry and confused, but mostly confused. What the hell was this about? What the hell did Deku *want* from him? He could tell there was something bigger at stake – something bigger making Deku upset –, but he couldn't, for the life of him, figure out what it was.

"Deku", he shook his head, going back to a normal tone of voice instead of shouting. "I don't know what you're saying".

Izuku breathed out a series of angry, harsh breaths, lowering his head and struggling against tears – tears of anger, frustration, and disappointment.

"What I'm saying", he said, voice strained, "is the only reason I'm *quirkless* is because you took my quirk. And you did it to save my life, and I'm grateful for it, but you've been calling me quirkless my whole life. You've been putting me *down* my whole life. And I'm tired", he locked eyes with Katsuki. "I'm tired of forgiving you".

Katsuki stared at him, lips parted and face blank.

"I told you. I *told* you this was the one thing I wouldn't forgive you for, and you went and did it anyway, right after I –", he trailed off, shaking his head. "And – And like you didn't even *care* –", he gasped, sniffing. "I told you how much it upset me, having people treat me like I'm made of porcelain, like I'm going to break. I told you how much I hate it, feeling weak and helpless and… and *useless*. You're the only one I told this to. But you went and you used it against me".

A pause. Katsuki stared at him in confused horror.

"And you know what?", Izuku sniffed, upset and angry. "Maybe my bruises aren't my body's fault. Maybe you're to blame for them, too. And I'm not going to sit around and tell you every time you're an asshole to me", he shook his head again. "You figure it out on your own from now on".

And just like that, he walked away.

"Deku", he called after him.

"Don't", Izuku said, not looking back.

"*Deku*", Katsuki insisted, following him.

"Don't *call* me that", Izuku snapped, sniffing, voice thick with hurt, tears rolling down his cheeks. He sounded sadder than angry, now. He also looked unbearably lost as he looked at Katsuki. "I trusted you. I *trusted* you, and you used it against me. And you called me… *that*, when you know very well the reason why I'm quirkless now".

Katsuki struggled to catch his breath, nervous and confused.

"I didn't mean to", was all he could say past the lump in his throat. His heart was breaking, and he couldn't understand why. He couldn't say the proper words. He desperately wanted to

feel angry and pissed off over Deku's reaction, but he couldn't. *I'm sorry. I'm sorry. I'm sorry.*

"Well, you did it anyway", Izuku sniffed again. "I could have helped. I could have dragged injured people to safety. I could have *done something*, if this was a real attack", he announced, bitter. "But you didn't even consider it, did you?"

"Because I didn't want to risk you getting hurt", Katsuki protested, desperate for Deku to *see*.

"Oh, yeah? And I'm supposed to believe that?"

He frowned, offended.

"What?! *Yes*", he said, as if it was obvious. "Haven't I made it clear –"

"What you *made clear* is that you don't respect me", Izuku cut him off. "Not yet, not in the slightest. You look at me and all you see is someone weak, useless. A *deku.* A quirkless deku. I tried telling you, I *told* you how I feel, but you don't even understand, do you? I said the actual words but you have no clue, you *still* have no clue, because that's all you see me as. As useless. As a *liability*".

Katsuki stared at him.

Izuku glared.

He didn't know what to say to make this better.

"Let me go, Kacchan", he said, and only then did Katsuki realize he had been holding his arm, grip tight. When had he done that?

He let go, shocked. He – he hadn't meant to hurt him; he didn't even know he was holding him.

And just like that, Izuku walked away without looking back.

Katsuki stood there, silent, watching as Deku got smaller and smaller and smaller until he disappeared from his view.

The cake felt tasteless and the happy birthday song sounded flat.

Everyone noticed there was something wrong when Katsuki came back, if not for the way Izuku had rushed by crying his heart out and leaving without a word, then from the empty look in Katsuki's eyes once he rejoined the group.

No one asked about it. Everyone had a vague idea what must have happened.

(After all, most of them had heard Katsuki's nightmares in the middle of the night at least once.)

Uraraka, Iida and Todoroki had left before the happy birthday song, chasing after Deku and not bidding anyone goodbye – the most he got was a disapproving glare from Todoroki. Everyone else who remained there felt awkward and weird as they ate their respective pieces of cake, and the ride back to UA was even tenser. Katsuki didn't say a single word on the way back, and no one tried to urge one out of him. Not even Kirishima, who sat beside Katsuki for the entirety of the ride, dared to ask him about what had happened. There were a few people trying to talk to each other as a way to diffuse the tension, but it felt forced and Katsuki didn't pay any attention to it either way.

Kirishima gave his best friend's shoulder a friendly, supportive squeeze once they arrived back at the dorm building, but said nothing as Katsuki left towards the stairs, trying to give him some time for himself. He certainly looked like he needed it.

Mina asked him if he wanted to keep the leftovers of cake on his room as he passed by the common room, trying to sound as nice and friendly as she could, but Katsuki didn't respond, simply walking past her with a look that, for the first time ever, was devoid of emotion – even of anger.

He climbed all the way up to his floor in silence, and stopped in front of his room. He was numbly surprised to find there was a wrapped gift there, sitting in front of his door, and from the All Might themed wrapping paper, he knew exactly who it was from.

Deku must have placed it there after Katsuki left with Kaminari, meaning to make it a surprise. Katsuki crouched down, picked it up, and entered his room, closing the door behind him.

The room was dark and empty, feeling too cold.

He walked inside, placed the wrapped box on the top of his laptop, grabbed the card attached to it and opened it.

From: Izuku

To: Kacchan

Happy Birthday to one of my favorite heroes! ^w^

He set the card down, staring at the wrapped gift. He stared for what felt years.

He didn't open it, kicking his pants off instead and allowing himself to drop to his bed. He turned his phone off and removed his hearing aid, suddenly feeling underwater, drowned in

silence, lost in it. He closed his eyes.

God, he really fucking hated spring.

Chapter End Notes

Happy birthday to Jesus only because Bakugou is having a crappy one

All jokes aside, happy holidays guys! I hope you all can forgive me for taking so long with this one. The end of the year is always rushed, right? Also, if you follow me on twitter, you'll (probably) know that this chapter was supposed to approach the flashback on the previous one, but it was getting too big and I had to split it in two again. But *part* of the flashback is there, right...? You know...? The "quirkless loser" thing...? No...? Ok...

This story is getting way bigger than I first planned, but we're almost done! My plan is to have four more chapters, so our ride with these oblivious boys is almost over :'-)

I hope you guys enjoyed this one! I have my insecurities about a lot of aspects of it and this is probably the chapter I worked the most on. I revised it and rewrote it several times over, so I hope it turned out ok. I also hope to publish the next one soon, because I'm REALLY eager to finish writing it! And I can't wait to see what you guys think of it either ^_^

I just don't feel like they woud immediately become buddy-buddy with each other, especially when Deku is still quirkless and amnesiac... Also, he has figured out he has the feelings™ (unlike *some* people), which only makes everything even harder. Can't Kacchan be a little tender to the baby bunny? :c

Thank you as always for your support! I would have given up on this story so long ago if it weren't for each and every one of you leaving me kudos and nice comments! You are really the best <3

Chapter 22: The Hedgehog's Dilemma

Chapter Notes

> I originally intended to post one single new chapter, but it was getting huge (over one hundred pages long), so I decided to split it into three parts. This is the first part. I hope you enjoy it!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

There, in the dark, are nine silhouettes, and one is reaching out for him.

Katsuki wants to scream. Is this it? Did he save them? Did he stop the villain? Is this it?

Is this what it feels like to be a hero?

“It’s ok”, the closest silhouette tells him. “It’s ok. You did great. Kacchan’s *sugoi*”.

“I – I d-did it, d-didn’t I? Did I d-do it?”, he gurgles out, and there’s something weird and alien at the back of his throat, making his voice sound breathy and restrained. He’s usually not this insecure about his own abilities – he knows that, despite everything, he *is* sugoi –, but he wants to be sure. He needs to be sure.

“You did it”, the silhouette tells him gently, offering him his hand. Katsuki doesn’t think about it, he can’t even remember how annoyed he used to be at seeing that hand reaching out for him – he takes it, grabs it, even if the action makes his shattered arm scream in protest. Actually, he can barely feel it anymore. He can barely feel anything. Taking the hand is now second nature to him – as it should have always been, as he always prevented it from being.

The silhouette kneels in front of him, and only then Katsuki realizes he’s lying on his back on the floor. When did this happen? When did he fall? He couldn’t remember.

He notices he can’t move, either. He tries, but he can’t. Why can’t he move? What was happening to him?

“It’s ok”, the silhouette tells Katsuki. He notices the other seven silhouettes stand far behind, and the eighth, whose hair looks suspiciously familiar, is standing halfway between Katsuki and the others. “It’s going to be ok”.

“You t-too?”, Katsuki swallows, turning his attention back to the ninth silhouette. “*M-Minna*?”

His voice sounds so weird. It’s rough and tight, constrained. Weak. Like his mom always said he was. He knew she loved him, and he loved her, but whenever he did something pathetic,

or weak, or wimpy, it was her voice he heard at the back of his head. *Weak. Useless. Spoiled. Wimpy. Whiny. Brat.*

Weak.

"Yes. Everyone will be just fine", the silhouette nods, trying to comfort him.

"Ok", he nods back. He swallows dry again, allows his head to fall back against the floor – apparently, he'd been craning his head up – and his eyes to slip shut. He allows himself to *breathe*. "O-Ok", he sighs, relief tangible in his husky voice.

He stares up at the sky with one eye, because the other one is swollen shut and covered in blood. It's so many miles above him, and it looks so pink, like Mina's skin. There's fire around him and maybe it's the fire making the sky look pink like Mina. And like Hatsume's hair. And like Izuku's lips… He realizes his heart is racing and it's getting hard to breathe, so he tries to calm himself down, tries to think about something good and relaxing that will make this easier, because there's a crushing weight above him, and he can't breathe, and his vision is getting darker at the edges, everything becoming blurry and fuzzy. He feels like a bug who's been pinned to the floor by a mean child, a child as mean as he himself had been, even if he had never hurt bugs before…

(But he did something worse than hurting a bug. He hurt a person.)

And he remembers Izuku's laugh, Izuku's freckles and dimples and beaming smile, the way he had found Katsuki's Christmas present so funny, the way he had seemed so happy as they lied down on his bed, with their heads hanging from the edge of the mattress, arms inches away from touching. The way his touch was the only one that didn't make Katsuki feel like his skin was itching, the way he felt like Deku was the only one who really knew the real him, his highest and lowest moments, even if they weren't so close, even with the amnesia. The way Deku would always praise him and admire him and call him *sugoi* and boost his already inflated ego expecting nothing in return.

The way his eyes had become tearful with hurt and pain when Katsuki called him a quirkless loser. The way he said he was tired of forgiving him. The way he acted like he didn't know Katsuki anymore, like he didn't get Katsuki anymore, the way they were out of tune with each other. The way he felt completely lost, because if Deku didn't know him anymore, then who would? Kirishima tried, and he was good at it, but there was shit Katsuki had never told him, like the roof crap he told Deku, and, well, would Kirishima want to stay friends with him? If he knew? Had Katsuki actually told him about it and forgotten afterwards? Did Kirishima already know and decided to leave and that was why he was lying there, staring at the sky? He couldn't remember. His thoughts were confusing and mixing together, and he didn't know himself, he couldn't… He couldn't recognize himself anymore, and that made him feel like a petal floating around aimlessly on a river stream, drifting and drifting and drifting without as much as his anger to keep him grounded –

"Don't pass out just yet", the silhouette tells him, sounding a bit nervous and worried.

It's too late, though. Katsuki's already being enveloped in black; he allows himself to be engulfed by it despite the voice at the back of his head screaming at him to *not fucking give*

up, you weak, pathetic brat, you need to survive this, don't give up like that!

"Kacchan? Kacchan, wait –"

Matte yo, Kacchan!

He's light. He's weightless. He's floating, drifting, fading away, with no means to ground him, nothing to cling to, nothing to hold on to. There's a hand reaching out for him, accompanied by worried, green, childish eyes, and Deku is a child standing above him on that river, asking him if he's ok and offering him his hand.

Instead of slapping it away, Katsuki tries to grab it, tries to hold on to it, but he's a moment too late and their fingertips brush but he doesn't manage to grab Deku's hand, still outstretched to him but getting father and farther away. He had been so close. But he missed. He missed, and now he was drifting, child Deku's wails of *Kacchan!* doing nothing to keep him grounded or bring him back.

God, they're out of sync. They're out of tune, they're playing at different frequencies. Whatever they say to each other is incomprehensible. Katsuki can't reach him, can't reach out to him. He's a split second too late, always, all the time.

Always behind. Like he'd always feared.

He doesn't give up on trying to reach back to Deku, who's barely a little dot in the infinite distance by now, because he can be a lot of things but a quitter isn't one of them. But he's too far away. And no matter how he tosses and turns and tries to catch some impulse, he can't go back.

He can't go back.

Katsuki's a sakura petal being led away by the stream, with no say in anything, with no way to ground himself, just floating with the current and floating and floating and floating and floating and floating and floating

until there's silence

…

..

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Katsuki spends his birthday – his actual birthday, that is: the day after the surprise party at the park – alone in his bedroom.

His parents start a video conference with him after his shitty dad basically cried and begged for him to pick up, even if they were perfectly aware of just how much their son hated this sort of thing. Their talk was brief – they wouldn't be able to visit him, but they still wanted to wish him a happy birthday and see how their son was faring up. When the old hag made a blunt comment about how he looked like he hadn't slept in days, Katsuki ended the conference without as much as bidding them goodbye.

His parents knew better then to try and call him again after that.

The present Deku had gotten him still sat unopened on his laptop. Katsuki stared at it from where he was sitting on his bed, and then he went right back to pretending there was nothing there.

He saw a few texts from his friends on his inbox – mostly Shitty Hair, Raccoon Eyes, and Dunce Face asking if he was fine. There was also one from Ears which consisted simply of a link, but Katsuki didn't bother opening it – he no longer had the app necessary to open the playlist she had made him.

The next few days went on like this – Katsuki, isolating himself from everything and everyone, whether it was in class, during lunchbreaks, or in the afternoons. He didn't bother sending Icy Hot a text asking if he would want to keep up their routine training schedule, since he knew damn well which side the multicolored bastard would be taking on this fight.

(He also knew better than trying to text Deku about anything at all.)

He knew why he had done what he did, even if, at the end of the day, there had been no threat to justify it. And, as much as it had hurt Deku, Katsuki knew he would do it again, as long as that meant the nerd wouldn't dive in headfirst into danger and get himself killed for the third time over.

Take a swan dive –

He closed his eyes, setting the phone aside without opening any of his unread chats .

His next appointment with Doctor Matsuo was scheduled for a little less than a few days ahead. He knew he wouldn't feel better after it, because he couldn't really explain the whole "I-called-Deku-quirkless-even-though-he-asked-me-not-to" situation without mentioning One For All and the fact that he was now its wielder, right? So he'd have to figure out something else to talk about. Or be really vague about what was bothering him. Or dodge it altogether, even if dodging problems wasn't exactly in his character.

He always faced his problems face-first. That was who he was. That was who he had always been. Right? It didn't matter that he isolated himself more often than not whenever something upset him; it didn't matter that shutting people out was his go-to strategy when it came to feeling shitty. Apart from these situations, he was pretty good at being straightforward towards his (other) problems. All Might had said so himself – Katsuki didn't cower in front of danger. He smiled.

He didn't really feel like smiling, now. Not even smugly.

He spent these days of isolations trying to remember every single advice Doctor Matsuo had ever given him on how to acknowledge his emotions and try to process them without resorting to anger. He could clearly recall her telling him that anger would always be the easy way out for him, since that was his comfort zone, and Katsuki would be damned if he resorted for the easy option like a coward.

The easy way would be for me to "suck it up" and just accept everything you say and do without thinking twice about it. But since when do you like to have things easy?

He sighed.

Thinking about how he felt was hard, but, to his own surprise, he didn't end up resorting to anger. It *would* be easy, and he wasn't supposed to do it in the first place, but he just… didn't feel like being angry in that moment. Like there was no room inside him for it. And, if he had to be honest, it kind of freaked him out.

Other than Deku, his only other constant was his anger. It had always been there, ever since he was a brat. Whether it was during a tantrum, or during a boasting session, or whenever shitty Deku breathed beside him, Katsuki was angry for as long as he could remember, replacing his other feelings with it, and while he could acknowledge that, in the long run, it had done him more harm than good, it was still… comforting, in a way. Hell, it had been his primary feeling for the majority of his life; it had been the only emotion he thought he could feel.

Now, thanks to Doctor Matsuo and the shitshow his life had become, he knew that he had always experienced other feelings – he just hadn't been able to identify them properly. But for years and years he had assumed that anger was his only possible emotion.

With therapy & co. ("co." meaning "every single shit that happened to him ever since the villain's attack and getting soulbound to Deku"), Katsuki learned how to try and interpret his emotions a little better. He was far from being 100% good at it, but he could discern between feelings of anger and, say, frustration, now. That didn't mean he necessarily knew what to do about a non-anger feeling all the time, which was why he still had his angry outbursts every now and then – hence the breakdown at Doctor Matsuo's office and… well.

The whole disaster with Deku at the park.

But even if Katsuki was still learning how to grasp his emotions and deal with them in a healthy, non-destructive way, his anger had remained there. It had been benched because of other feelings, yes, but it had always *stayed* there, nagging at the back of his mind, always

hidden like a second option, like a comforting secret, like a trick up his sleeve. And, as Deku had exhaustively pointed out in their last two conversations, Katsuki was still as harsh, rude, and foul-mouthed as he had always been, but the fact that he had managed to tone down his anger enough to make room for some gentleness and empathy was enough to show how he wasn't letting the worst of him suppress the best of him anymore.

Well, at least he was trying to.

But now, in that moment, there was no worse or best. He wasn't quite sure what he was anymore; but he knew he wasn't angry. Deku was gone from his life, and, so it seemed, was his anger. All he felt was – dull. Kind of numb. Lost, if he had to think about it.

He didn't, actually. *Have* to think about it. In fact, he had spent enough time thinking about shitty Deku and his shitty mood-swings. The fuck had he spent months without complaining for? If Katsuki's behavior had been bothering him so much, why didn't he say something instead of having *one* freak-out session at him and cutting him off from his life altogether?

Stupid piece of shit. Useless fucking nerd. Katsuki *hated* him.

(Even the cussing inside his head felt half-hearted from the lack of anger, which was starting to verge on ridiculous).

Christ, what had his life become? Why did he ever allow himself to be so affected by what shitty Deku said and what shitty Deku did? Because it really was like he said – he wasn't about to waste his time worrying about his grown-ass friends unless their guts were falling off their bodies or they were bleeding to death. So why waste so much time and energy on worrying about what shitty fucking Deku decided to do with his damn life? Katsuki shouldn't care. He shouldn't give a shit.

But, at the same time, none of Katsuki's friends had died in front of him. None of them had spent a month with their souls glued to him, feeling everything that he felt, going everywhere he went. None of them had thrown their lives away from him. None of them had flatlined in front of him. None of them had done the things Deku did, and none of them would ever be able to understand, or ever be able to have the same connection Katsuki now had with Deku. With the *true* Deku – the Deku who remembered, the Deku who had been his companion for a month, the Deku who he still had nightmares about and who understood Katsuki's feelings, and Katsuki's thought process, and Katsuki's way of living. Not this confusing, weird-ass, amnesiac, whiny version of Deku.

And to think he'd complained so much about being stuck with Deku in the past. If only he could have *that* version of Deku back, he'd be happy. He wouldn't be so frustrated. Maybe he could even go back to having that comforting sense of anger looming deep inside him, ready to resurface whenever he needed it, instead of being absent.

His lack of anger felt like a phantom limb, throbbing and aching and hurting precisely because it wasn't there. He needed it. He wanted it back. All he had left were these conflicting, confusing feelings, which he couldn't discuss with anyone, because no one *knew*, and as much of an asshole as he was, he wasn't about to spill All Might's secret just because he felt *bad*.

There were things bigger than his feelings at stake. So he had to go through this alone.

Yeah. He'd always fared off way better on his own. He had always been a lone wolf. Yeah, That... That was right. He'd lost Deku; he'd lost his anger; so his solitude was all he had left. Deku didn't want him to be so fucking harsh all the damn time? Katsuki couldn't be harsh if there wasn't anyone around.

Yeah, that was a good solution. He opened his chat with Doctor Matsuo and typed down a shitty excuse about not being able to attend the next session.

His thumb hovered above the send button, and Katsuki hesitated.

He always felt a bit better after talking to his therapist, but not being able to talk about what he really wanted to say always left him frustrated and a bit nervous, if he was being honest. Being purposefully vague so she wouldn't figure out All Might's secret was exhaustive, and honestly, he wished he could just *talk about it* to someone, someone who wouldn't potentially turn into a threat – or worse, *be* threatened – because of this secret he was forced to carry. He wished he could talk about it to someone who wouldn't be forced to choose his or Deku's side.

He wished he could just fall apart, without this constant fear of being seen as lessen, as inferior, as weak, as pathetic, as everything he had always seen Deku as, as everything he had always projected onto Deku. He wished he could be vulnerable without being *weak.*

He ended up not sending the message to Doctor Matsuo, but the nervous twirling at the bottom of his stomach remained – for he knew that, however his next session went down, it would probably still leave him feeling like there was something missing inside him – like a part of his soul had been severed away.

He glared up at the dorm building after the session, taking a deep breath and mustering the courage he needed.

Whatever happened, if you feel in your heart that you were in the wrong and that you made a mistake… Apologize.

Katsuki clicked his tongue, swallowing dry.

There's always a chance he won't accept it, yes, but if your apology is honest and thoughtful, and if you really regret whatever it is that you did to him, you will have done your part. That's one of the ways you can find closure, if the situation isn't solved.

And Katsuki knew – he knew he had been in the wrong when he called Deku quirkless. He'd been angry, and afraid, and desperate, but he knew exactly what effect his words would have on the nerd. And that was precisely *why* he had said them – he needed Deku to step back, and he wasn't listening. He would do it all over again if it came down to it, but he was well aware of how much he had hurt him.

So yeah, Doctor Matsuo was right – an apology wouldn't go amiss. Especially since he had broken his promise.

After everything they had already gone through – after the times in which he actually managed to apologize to Deku in the past –, this should be easy, right? Just walk up to him, say you're sorry, be done with it. There. Everything goes back to normal.

It wasn't easy.

He walked into the building, ready to climb the stairs up to Deku's bedroom. It was around the time they usually trained sign language – Katsuki would come back from his weekly session with Doctor Matsuo and stop by at Deku's bedroom so they could practice. So it was probable Deku would be in his room.

He'd been thinking about that a lot, recently – how the little details of their routine, to which they had gotten used to, would change if they continued giving each other the cold shoulder. No more training sessions, no more sign language, no more awkward conversations in Deku's room. No more teasing, no more touching, no more ruffling green curls until they were so messy it looked ridiculous. No more sugoi's or praises or blushes or deer eyes. Katsuki would have to get used to a life with no Deku in it, at least until he got his quirk and his memories back.

He wanted to scoff. To think that, back when he first learned that Deku was amnesiac, he had planned to do precisely that – keep his distance and wait until Deku was fit to get One For All back, without talking to him, or seeing him. Now, in sharp contrast, he was willing to humiliate himself and apologize, to *Deku*, *again*, just so that they could keep talking and seeing to each other. His whole damn life had really gone down a spiral of fucking nonsense, hadn't it? He wondered what he would look like to his past self.

Pathetic.

And now he was hyper-aware that Deku getting his quirk back didn't mean an immediate solution to all his problems, on the top of everything. They wouldn't get their emotional affinity back. They wouldn't get their singular empathy back. If anything, Deku would hate him even more than he already did – for all the shit Katsuki put his amnesiac self through, when he could have been clearer, when he could have been kinder.

But wasn't that who he was? And didn't Deku himself say he admired Katsuki for that? For being ruthless, and angry, and blunt, and harsh? Didn't he say he liked him? Didn't he say he *loved* him? Didn't he praise him his whole life, even when Katsuki kicked him like a stray dog? Even when Katsuki shut him out with no explanation and ignored him and told him to kill himself? Why did Katsuki's regular behavior suddenly start to bother Deku so much?

Why did Deku suddenly decide to make demands and request for changes that he never even mentioned before?

Maybe Deku had been right and they *did* need to talk things out. Because, as upsetting as it had been, their last fight left him more confused than anything. There were a lot of things he wasn't sure he had gotten right, and Deku's final speech – the shit about saying his name, about Katsuki waiting for others to beg, about telling Katsuki how he felt – had been really weird and messy. First, because it came out of nowhere; two, because Katsuki couldn't really feel angry about it; three, because it really did feel like there was a secret meaning behind the asshole's words, a meaning he couldn't really figure out.

Almost a week had passed since the fight, so maybe Deku had cooled off and would accept talking to him, right? If Katsuki apologized to him? And maybe they could come clear with each other. He could explain why he called Deku quirkless – even if he had already gone over the whole 'I-care-about-you' thing for what felt like a hundred times over by now –; Deku could explain what on earth he had been talking about.

But he hated the idea so much. Lowering himself, humiliating himself like that *again*, all because shitty Deku didn't bother to come clear with his feelings. Because shitty Deku waited for months to say something. Katsuki couldn't help but to feel like Deku was looking down on him again, even if he was more than aware by now that this wasn't – couldn't be – true.

But if it wasn't true, then why did the fucking nerd seem so keen on giving Katsuki morality lessons and making him apologize for shit he'd already said he was sorry for? Why did he keep conveniently forgetting that Katsuki cared about him, and that he didn't want him to die? Why did he seem to be overcome by happiness and joy whenever Katsuki admitted he'd been a piece of shit? Did he like to see him suffer? Did he get off on Katsuki's humiliation?

And, on the top of all that, why was *he* the one who needed to chase after Deku? All he had done was to prevent the asshole from potentially getting himself killed – he should be getting a fucking *thank you*, not this whole weird cold-shoulder thing.

And Deku was such a smug little bastard, wasn't he? Maybe he'd been faking it the entire time. Maybe he never fucking admired Katsuki whatsoever, maybe all his praising and his bullshit "*sugoi*"'s were just a scam, just a sarcastic way to disguise the contempt he really felt for "*Kacchan"*. Maybe he thought that, even quirkless, he was better than Katsuki, and the possibility that he actually *was* better than him scared Katsuki beyond belief.

I know you think horrible things of me, and I don't know what I could have possibly done to make you think them, but I thought we had cleared things up after our fight! Apparently, I was wrong, since you continue to see me as this horrible, fake person, while, to me, you're nothing less than the very incarnation of victory!

Katsuki sighed.

He took a deep breath and tried to organize his thoughts. Because this sudden stream of insecurity proved exactly what he had been fearing – that he was back to step one with Deku.

Fuck.

Fine. *Fine*. He *knew* Deku didn't look down on him – at least, he knew that now, okay? But just like resorting to his anger was comfortable to him, thinking Deku was a fake-ass loser who belittled him was easier than admitting that he had fucked up.

The words *quirkless loser* and *take a swan dive off the roof of the building* appeared in his memory, and he begrudgingly admitted that *fine*, he could lower himself just a bit and just this once, because he had *really* messed up. So yeah, he was going to apologize to Deku like Doctor Matsuo suggested. Happy now?

Katsuki took pride in being a man of his word. He had promised Deku he wouldn't call him quirkless again, and he had broken that promise – even if it had been to protect the nerd and to prevent him from getting himself killed *again*. So the least he could do was apologize for his lack of word, and restore Deku's faith in his honor. Then, they could do as shitty Deku had suggested and just talk about their feelings for once, because there was a lot of shit Katsuki still wanted to understand from Deku's little speech.

God, this was fucking ridiculous, wasn't it? It felt like they were going through the same conversations and the same fights all over and over again, stuck in an endless roundabout of feelings. Katsuki would have to be as clear as he possibly could this time, because he wasn't sure he would have the patience to go through this whole shit *yet again* next time they went toe-to-toe.

He climbed the steps of the dorm building with gritted teeth and fisted hands, a grumpy expression on his face already. He would go to Deku's bedroom, he would apologize to him, and he would explain his point of view to the shitty nerd – that he knew he had been a jackass for calling him quirkless and breaking his promise, and that he also knew that he was ready to do anything in his power to keep Deku from being a dipshit and getting himself hurt again. That he couldn't *bear* to see him hurt again when there was something he could do to stop it. That he cared about him, and wanted to protect him.

(And that he still had nightmares about losing him –)

A noise coming from the common room caught Katsuki's attention as he walked by, and he turned his head to look. Some people were gathered there, talking and giggling cheerfully.

Deku was there, sitting on the couch, sandwiched between Half'n'Half and Round face. Class Rep and Frog Girl were sitting in front of them, big smiles on their faces. Half'n'Half said something that actually earned a *laugh* out of the group – *what the fuck?* –, but Katsuki couldn't hear it from where he was standing. He might have in the past, when his hearing was still fully functional.

Frog Girl was the first one to notice Katsuki was watching them, and it didn't take too long for the whole group to follow her line of sight and turn around to see what she was staring at. Their curious expressions turned into silent expectation as realized it was *Katsuki* was standing there, glaring at them.

Deku was the last one to crane his neck, and as his eyes locked with Katsuki's, the atmosphere of the room grew strained.

Katsuki searched Deku's eyes – for what, exactly, he did not know. Maybe hatred, or anger, or resentment, or disdain. But all he found there was curiosity with a hint of anticipation, as if he was waiting to see what Katsuki would do.

But what Katsuki couldn't help but to realize was that Deku had looked and sounded happy until a second before. And although his eyes were sparkling with a vivid sense of expectation, his lips had bent downwards, and there was misery written all over his face.

Because Katsuki was there.

You're a fucking liability!

Right now you're a quirkless loser, and you'll end up getting yourself killed again.

I'm harsh, and I'm raw, and I'm wild. I know all that. And I don't think I can be anything else. What I'm trying to be is someone who hurts you less.

Izuku watched him, eyes glistening and face sad.

Katsuki stared at him.

And then he looked away.

What I'm trying to be is someone who hurts you less.

"Tch", he scoffed, shoving his hands deep into his pockets before walking past the common room and going to his bedroom in silence.

Maybe he was back to feeling a bit angry, now, after this. Just a bit. And at least that meant he didn't feel so empty anymore.

"Could you pass me that paper, please?"

"There".

"Thank you, Kacchan".

"Mm".

“Oh! Sorry, I didn’t see you there”.

“That’s fine”.

“Uh – C-Could you let me through, please?”

“Oh. Right, yeah”.

“Thanks, Kacchan”.

“Tch”.

“Have… Have a good night”.

“Yeah”.

“Good evening, everyone!”

“Hi, Midoriya!”

“Hey!”

“Are you guys going to watch that movie tomorrow?”

“Sure!”

“Well, not *all* of us…”

“Shut up, Kaminari”.

“Well, that’s great! I’ll see you guys tomorrow, then!”

“All right, see ya!”

“Bye, guys!”

“Bye, Midoriya!”

“Are you going to use that?”

“No”.

“Can I take it?”

“There”.

“Thank you, Kacchan”.

“Yeah”.

“Can I borrow the other one, too?”

“Just fucking take whatever”.

“Ok”.

“So, the other day I was training with Todoroki-kun, right, and I learned a new move I didn’t even know I could do yet, I mean, I don’t even know if I could have done it *before* all this…”

“I’m glad to hear it, Midoriya”.

“You sure are looking better, Deku-kun!”

“*Hai*! Your recovery process is improving every day!”

“You are amazing, Midoriya-kun!”

“Kero! We’re really proud of you, Midoriya-chan!”

“T-Thanks, guys… I really couldn’t do it without you!”

“Dude”.

“What?”

“You…”

“*What*?”

“You should. I don’t know. You should talk to him”.

A sigh.

“Kirishima”.

“I don’t know. I think he’s willing to talk to you. I really do. I mean… It’s been almost two months. I’m pretty sure he’s cooled down. If you try –“

“I’m not trying shit”.

A pause.

“I’m just saying he’d talk to you if you –“

“I know what you’re saying. And *I’m* saying I’m not doing it”.

“… Why not?”

A scoff.

“Deku was pretty clear. He said he didn’t want to hear what I had to say. So I ain’t gonna crawl after him. I did what I had to do”.

“And what *did* you do?”

Silence.

“I mean… You never talked about it. *We* never talked about it. Things were going pretty great, and then something happened, and no one wanted to ask either of you about it because… Well. That’s your business”.

“Well put. That means it’s none of *your* business”.

A sigh, tired.

“Dude, c’mon. This’s been going on long enough. What happened? Why did you and Midoriya fight?”

Katsuki was silent.

“Or, better – what sort of fight could have been so bad that you treat each other like you’re just acquaintances now, after everything you two went through? This is even worse than before, when you hated him. At least *then* you still talked to each other, even if it was just to yell”.

Katsuki stood up abruptly.

“Like I said, it’s none of your business”.

Kirishima stood up as well.

“I know it’s not. It’s *your* business, and you’re my friend. I’m just worried about you”.

“You don’t have to be. I’m fine”.

Kirishima shook his head sadly.

“You’re not”.

Katsuki glared at him.

“Don’t tell me what I am. Don’t fucking tell me what I’m *supposed* to be”.

Silence.

“Katsuki…”

“Just leave me the fuck alone, Kirishima”.

He walked away.

“You shouldn’t keep isolating yourself, you know”.

“And you shouldn’t shove your nose on other people’s business”.

“I’m just trying to help”.

“I didn’t ask you to”.

“Great. Yeah, you know what? That’s great. You’re gonna be a great hero if you keep that up, Bakugou”.

“You can take your sarcasm and shove it, Ears. I didn’t ask you to fucking pep talk me, and I sure as fuck don’t need it”.

“Yeah, you didn’t. I’m just an idiot for trying, right?”

“Fuck you”.

“Fuck you too. I won’t sit around and watch you ruin every good relationship you have in life”.

“Then don’t sit around and watch”.

“I won’t”.

“Then *leave*”.

“Bakugou”.

He glared at her.

She deflated a bit, noticing the hurt hidden behind the anger in his eyes.

“I won’t do that”, she shook her head. “I’m staying right here. But you need to stop this, whatever this is. This is harming you more than us”.

“I’m perfectly fine”.

“No, you’re not”.

“Yes, I am”.

“Yeah. Is that why you’re eating katsudon for the fourth time this week?”

His ears burned.

“What, you’re stalking me or something, weirdo?”

“No. I just overheard Midoriya complaining about the mysterious disappearance of his favorite dish the other day, and turns out I didn’t have to dig too deep into it”.

He scoffed.

“Consider this my petty revenge against him, then”.

“Sure. And this has nothing to do with the fact you miss him”.

If looks could kill, Jirou would have been terminated on the spot.

“I don’t *miss* him”.

She sighed.

“Look, all I’m saying is…”, she trailed off, shaking her head. “Look. Look”, he reached forwards, grabbing his hand and squeezing it. She looked serious. “I – I’m here. Ok?”

He scoffed.

“I don’t *need* you”.

“Yeah, sure, you’re a big, independent boy with no emotional problems whatsoever. Just…”, she sighed again, sounding fed up and lowering her head. “I *told* you to fix it”.

“Yeah”.

“And you didn’t”.

Katsuki looked away for a moment before glaring at her again. He pulled his hand from her grasp.

“No use in fixing something that keeps getting broken all over again”.

Jirou was silent after that. Katsuki finished his katsudon just as quietly.

All Might didn’t talk about it, which made Katsuki glad, really.

He knew All Might was on Deku's side on this – when wasn't he, really? –, but the fact that he was still professional and considerate enough to keep training with him despite the fucked-up shit Katsuki had put his mentee through…

Well. Katsuki understood why Deku admired All Might so much.

You are the person Midoriya shonen holds the most admiration, love, devotion, and reverence for.

As it seemed, not anymore.

But it was noticeable that All Might wasn't being as talkative as he had been on their previous training sessions throughout the past months, which was enough of an indicator that he had, in fact, probably spoken to Deku and knew all about the shit that went down on Katsuki's birthday.

Speaking of birthdays, Deku's was already next week. Time flies when you're a hero in training, and after his fight with Deku, he found himself with a lot more spare time to study and work hard – well, at least harder than he had before, since he'd been so busy training sign language with stupid Deku or sparring with him at the gym. Days seemed to blend together and pass unnoticeably, now that he didn't do those things anymore, and before Katsuki knew it, July was already at the door.

And, with that, Deku's birthday.

But no one had invited him to anything – not that he expected them to –, and he hadn't heard any of his shitty friends discussing any plans. The only reason Katsuki knew it was Deku's birthday was because…

Well. He didn't really know why. But after over a decade of seeing the nerd on a daily basis, he was bound to memorize it, right?

But truth be told, he was sort of relieved no one had talked to him about it. Having one of his friends ask him if he was attending the party would result in an awkward conversation, and, if he could be grateful for small miracles, then he'd be glad that this bunch of losers had finally found some common sense and decided to leave him out of any possible plans for Deku's shitty birthday party.

It still made his chest throb, though. He couldn't really tell why, and he felt stupid for feeling that way. It was just a shitty birthday party, and Deku didn't want him there. So why should he care? It's not like he hadn't missed every single one of Deku's birthdays for a decade in a row.

(Deku hadn't missed his, though, but that was a whole other conversation).

But, again, he couldn't really talk to anyone about how this shit bothered him, especially not to All Might, of all people. Maybe he should see a cardiologist about all those chest-throbbing and shit.

“How are you faring up, Bakugou *shonen*?”, All Might asked him after one of the exercises were over, the first time he spoke to Bakugou in a conversational tone ever since their daily training began. So far, he had only welcomed him and given him careful instructions while Katsuki did his assigned exercises.

“Fine”, Katsuki spat out shortly with a pant as he got himself ready for the next series of exercises. “You?”

All Might was silent. Katsuki turned his head to look at him at the lack of a response.

He looked surprised. Katsuki frowned.

“What?”

All Might blinked, seeming to come to his senses.

“Nothing. It was – nothing, *shonen*. I’m fine. Thank you for asking”, he said, something akin to pride in his voice.

“Tch”.

The rest of the session was silent. It was only when they were done for the day, Katsuki dripping sweat and feeling like he could eat a truck full of food and sleep for 80 years, that All Might spoke to him in a conversational tone again.

“I only asked how you were”, he said, placing a comforting hand on Katsuki’s shoulder, “because you’re looking tired”.

Katsuki swallowed, looking away from All Might for a moment before shrugging his hand away.

“I’m fine”, he said in a monotone, not meeting his eyes.

“Are you sure?”, All Might insisted.

“Well, *yeah*”, he scoffed, sharp. He didn’t need All Might’s sympathy or pity – he didn’t need All Might to pretend he was on his side, when he knew he was on Deku’s.

All Might studied him for a moment, serious, before nodding.

“If you need anything…”

Katsuki closed his eyes for a moment. He didn’t need All Might to pretend he cared for him. He didn’t need All Might to pretend he wasn’t pissed for what he’d done to Deku, in the middle of his recovery, just when he was starting to get better.

Midoriya shonen needs you. More than ever. And something tells me that you need him, too.

“Yeah, I know”, he said sharply before All Might could continue. Before All Might could make promises he wouldn’t keep, like Katsuki himself had done, because at the end of the

day, it was Deku who was his chosen one, and not him.

Not him. He shouldn't even have this power coursing within him in the first place, because he hadn't been chosen. He hadn't *earned* it.

"I mean it", All Might insisted, serious. If Katsuki had known better, he would have noticed the worried undertone of his voice.

"Yeah", he said simply, not looking at the man.

There was no more harshness in Katsuki's tone – just a stern, flat, emotionless tune to it as he grabbed his bag and walked away.

Katsuki didn't hear anything about Deku's birthday, but he saw the photos by accident on social media.

Shitty Hair had made a feeble attempt at inviting Katsuki, but he knew it had been more out of politeness than an actual expectation that he'd attend. Therefore, before Kirishima could even elaborate a coherent invitation, Katsuki cut him off, telling him he was busy for the day with a made-up sign language exam.

Mina, Kaminari, and even Round Face had attempted to invite him, but it was fruitless. Katsuki offered them the same excuse, and, from the tone of his voice, they knew better than to insist.

They had gone to an arcade downtown. Probably the safest course – for Deku's immune system, for his recovering body, for everything. At least it was better than dragging the loser to a fucking park overflowing with flowers and pollen and all that shit, and Deku had always liked arcades. Katsuki could remember that much.

Back when they were kids there was this shitty All Might game at their neighborhood arcade, and Deku used to be obsessed with it. He'd shown Katsuki the game and they played it together for a week straight, until Katsuki got bored and demanded they played something else. And Deku had whined and whined and whined about wanting to play the All Might game only, until Katsuki found someone else to play the game he wanted with him and left Deku alone to his annoying crying.

Deku looked happy, in the photos. His smile was wide, and he was surrounded by his friends in front of an All Might game. It wasn't the same one from when they were kids, but it was obviously All Might themed, his trademark smile standing out behind Deku's.

He looked stronger, too. Katsuki hadn't allowed himself to look at Deku for too long these past months, so he hadn't really noticed his progress. All he'd do was glimpse at him, and not meet his eyes, and avoid talking to him more than necessary. Did his mumbling sessions from behind him during class still drive Katsuki insane? Yeah. Did he eventually ask Katsuki for something in that alien, polite, distant tone as if they were just two guys who happened to know each other from school? Yeah.

Did Katsuki feel like looking into those eyes and seeing the hurt in them? Did Katsuki feel like talking to Deku and watching his smile disappear from his lips? Did Katsuki feel like remembering his dead eyes and limp body and the sound of his heart monitor as he flatlined?

No. Definitely not.

But staring at a *picture* of Deku on his feed, which had been posted by Round Face a few minutes before, was way easier. This way, Katsuki could bring himself to look at Deku without risking wiping his smile away or starting an uncomfortable conversation. He could notice how his body looked more in shape than when Katsuki had last trained with him. He could see how his cheeks had a healthier color. He could even see the faint outline of his biceps – they weren't as big or strong as they had been before the incident, but it was obvious that Deku was doing a good job at building back his muscle mass, however slowly.

A dark part of his brain whispered that maybe Icy Hot was better at training with Deku than he was. Maybe Katsuki had been too distracted by lips and freckles and hair; maybe he should have dedicated himself harder. Maybe he shouldn't have gone so easy on Deku; or maybe he shouldn't have been so hard on him. He didn't know. Maybe he shouldn't have done a lot of shit; maybe he should have been better.

There it was again, the insecurity that seemed to accompany him everywhere he went. What sucked the most about anger management therapy, Katsuki figured, was that, before, he could hide his insecurity behind his rage fits and be done with it. Now, what was he supposed to do? Let *people know* he was *vulnerable*? Hah. What a fucking joke.

As *if*.

"Tch", he clicked his tongue, locking his phone screen and putting the device away.

He lied on his bed for a while, glaring up at his ceiling his hands beneath his head.

Then, he made up his mind.

He took the chance that Deku and his friends were still out at the arcade and got up from his bed, walking out of his room and stopping by Deku's. He didn't enter it, because that would be creepy as fuck, even if he knew the idiot forgot his door unlocked more often than not. Instead, he crouched down in front of the closed door and placed the carefully wrapped All Might T-shirt he had gotten him by the doorframe.

Katsuki had wondered about that a lot, the past days. Whether he should actually give Deku the gift he had gotten him, or if he should simply pretend the birthday never happened, as if he didn't remember it at all.

Deku and he weren't on speaking terms, and the fact that they were acting civil to each other for what had to be the first time in their lives only made everything worse. If Deku merely hated him, things would be easier on Katsuki. All he would have to do was to hate Deku back and be done with it. But as much as the nerd had told him he wouldn't forgive him anymore, and as angry and disappointed he had seemed back on that day when they fought in the park…

He didn't seem like he hated Katsuki.

He didn't talk like he hated Katsuki, he didn't act like he hated Katsuki. And, to be honest, that was what made everything worse. They were no longer enemies, no longer rivals, no longer friends. They were still stuck in that limbo of being nothing at all, but at a deeper level, because having to act like Deku didn't change his life and himself and everything he ever knew, everything he ever believed in, was a thousand times worse than something as simple as just hating him. Having to act like they meant *nothing* to each other was worse than being his friend.

Their relation had always been complicated and hard to define, but this seemed to be its lowest point. They couldn't even bear to make eye contact with each other anymore. What a fucking joke.

But for some reason, he decided to give the nerd his damn birthday present and be done with it. He tried not to think too much about it, and what finally made him come to this decision was the realization that, if they hated each other, everything would be easier.

But he never liked to have things easy.

Deku wanted to pretend they didn't know each other for over a decade? He wanted to act like they were mere acquaintances? He wanted to stick to that demented illusion that Katsuki didn't give a shit about him? Too bad. Katsuki wouldn't let him. And that was the only direct action he could take at that point of their stale relationship.

It was a bit spiteful, yes, but Katsuki was past beyond the point of caring. And maybe this way he could show Deku that, whatever he thought, whatever he had brought himself to think about how Katsuki felt, he was *wrong*. Katsuki couldn't bring himself to say the actual words, but he would show shitty Deku. He would *show* him.

(Not that this strategy had worked so far.)

There was no birthday card or note or any of that touchy-feely shit Deku seemed to love so much, only a "to / from" sticker glued to the All Might themed wrapping paper. He stared at the gift, which was now sitting in front of Deku's closed door.

From: Katsuki

To: Izuku

He went back to his own room.

"Bro, if you ever need to talk…"

"Kirishima".

"I mean it. I – I mean. I feel kind of bad. For not insisting that you went to, uh, you know. The…"

"I know".

A pause.

"I just didn't want to put you in that position. Or to make things weird for you. You know?"

"I know".

"*No one* wanted that. I thought – I thought it'd be better if we didn't push it".

"Stop overthinking this crap, Shitty Hair. I said it's fine".

A pregnant pause.

"You don't look fine, man. You… You haven't looked fine for ages".

Katsuki sighed. Why did people keep telling him that?

He was fine. He was fucking *fine.* There was *nothing* wrong with him.

"I *am* fine", he retorted.

Kirishima gave him a sad look.

"Dude…"

"Just drop it, Hair For Brains", he snapped, irritated. "I'm fine. Even if I wasn't, whining about it wouldn't help. Just leave me alone and I'll figure my shit out. Pushing me around will just make things worse".

Kirishima stared at him for a moment.

“Yeah, I… I know”, he said, lowering his head. “I just… I worry about you, man”.

“You don’t have to. I can take care of my damn self”.

Kirishima gave him a sad smile.

“Yeah… And you seem to be doing better”.

Katsuki frowned, squinting at his best friend as if that was the stupidest thing he had ever heard.

“You *just* said I haven’t looked fine in ages. Make up your damn mind”, he scoffed, annoyed.

“No, I – I mean”, Kirishima chuckled nervously. “You haven’t. looked fine, that is. But you seem to be doing better at this… talking-about-your-feelings thing”, he shrugged, giving Katsuki a tentative smile.

Katsuki scoffed, not meeting Kirishima’s eyes. More than ever, he wanted to be left alone before they could go down that road, but Kirishima didn’t seem to get the hint.

“I mean, in comparison to before”, he continued. “You’re still pretty dull at some stuff, but –“

“*The fuck* did you say?!”

“– overall, I think you’re being more honest, with yourself and with other people. Well. *Most* people”, he continued, unaffected by Katsuki’s rageful reaction.

Katsuki glared at him with the intensity of a thousand suns, face twisted in a furious scowl. Kirishima shrugged and offered him a lopsided smile.

“You really are *sugoi*, Bakugou”.

Yeah, fuck. He definitely hadn’t seen that coming.

The words deflated him from his angered state, but they didn’t have the same ring to…

Hmph.

Well. If anything, they only served to make him feel even *more* bitter. Nice going, Shitty Hair.

Kirishima, unaware of his friend’s reaction or even of the weight behind his own words, continued:

“But what you’ve been going through can’t be easy. And you don’t have to do this alone. We’re here for you, ok?”

Katsuki stared at him.

His instinct was to scream at Kirishima to mind his own business and never fucking call him *sugoi* again. But for a while now, he knew better than to pretend he didn't value Kirishima's friendship, and his companionship, and his loyalty to him. Katsuki knew that, no matter how bad things got, he could always count on Shitty Hair to be there for him and have his back. Even if didn't need him to, and even if Kirishima could be kind of annoying at some times.

If this conversation had happened a year before, things would have turned out very differently. *Very* differently.

Now, all Katsuki did was point Kirishima with a final glare and look away.

"Tch. Yeah".

"I mean it", his friend insisted, not satisfied with that answer.

Katsuki sighed.

"I *know* you do", he said, clearly trying to put an end to that sappy talk before he lost the already feeble grip that was holding his anger back.

"Just… Please, don't push me away this time?"

Katsuki scoffed, frowning. He squinted at Kirishima.

"What are you talking about?"

"You… You always do this, man", Kirishima shrugged, looking almost apologetic. "You're having a problem with Midoriya, you shut everyone else out. Actually, if you're having a problem with *anything*, you shut everyone out. And you isolate yourself, and… I don't know. It's just not healthy for you".

Katsuki looked away again, his expression a mixture of grumpy and pensive. Maybe this was a cycle he couldn't break away from, because he *knew*, deep down, that Kirishima was right. If anything, he'd been thinking about that for a while now, but without knowing how to put it into words like Kirishima had done.

This pattern of isolating himself was becoming a habit, and it felt cyclical, like a dog chasing its own tail, like a rat trapped on a maze – like that ridiculous roundabout of feelings. That was what his whole relationship with Deku felt like as well – a cycle, a maze, one of those Groundhog Day fucking situations. It was good, then it got bad. Then it got good, then it got bad. Then good, then bad. Good, bad, good, bad, always black and white, always hot or cold. Just when they were almost done making it good again, the whole thing got reset and they went back to the starting point.

He becomes friends with Deku? Deku finds out he's quirkless and, therefore, Katsuki sees him as lessen for years. He becomes friends with Deku again? His ghost goes back to his body and he wakes up a month later with no memories. Becomes friends with Deku again? He gets pissed for no longer having his quirk. Becomes friends again? He gets pissed Katsuki called him quirkless. It's like they can't fucking break away from it. Like they're bound to

fight, no matter how well they fare for a short while. Like they aren't meant to be together after all.

It's like Izuku is the nitroglycerin and Katsuki is the ignition. It's only a matter of time before they blow up again. They're two extremes; they can never find a middle ground. Never compromise.

You keep talking as if I'm the only one who needs to do something. As if the only options are me accepting everything you do, or me walking away. Nothing is that binary, Kacchan. There has to be a third option. A – A middle ground we can find, between you being yourself and you…

Tch.

"You don't have to do this alone", Kirishima concluded, unaware of Katsuki's thoughts.

He stared at his friend.

"I'm not alone, Shitty Hair. You just said I've got you and the rest of our shitty friends, didn't you?", he said, a bit harsh.

Kirishima's reaction was a bit disappointing. Katsuki had expected a chuckle, or even a beaming smile, sparkly eyes, maybe even some dimples or an excited praise.

All he got was a sad, almost apologetic smile as Kirishima placed a comforting hand on his shoulder and squeezed it in support.

"Yeah, man. You know you can always count on me and on the guys. But you also know this isn't about us", he said, standing up.

Katsuki scoffed again, glaring at Kirishima. He was silent, and Kirishima sighed again.

"*Talk* to him, Bakugou. For real, this time. I swear to you you'll feel better if you do".

Kirishima sounded serious, out of a sudden. Katsuki sniffed, a scornful scowl on his face. Shitty Hair *had* to ruin the friendly talk, hadn't he? He had thought they were past talking about Deku, but there Kirishima was, making the conversation about him again.

"You can't know that", Katsuki protested, bitter.

"I *do* know that", Kirishima nodded emphatically.

Katsuki narrowed his eyes at him in suspicion, and Kirishima simply squeezed his shoulder again.

"You're never happier than when you're with him, bro. You're also never sadder than when you're apart. That's how things have been ever since that whole soulbond thing".

Katsuki frowned at Kirishima as if he'd suddenly grown two heads, shrugging away from his touch in confusion and indignation.

“I ain’t *sad*”, he protested, confused and offended.

He *wasn’t* sad. He’d know if he was. He felt sick, and tired, and empty, sometimes, but he didn’t feel sad. He’d gone back to feeling a bit angry, which was comforting in a way, but he wasn’t *sad*. He’ know.

He *would know*.

Kirishima sighed tiredly, giving Katsuki a pat on the back.

“Just talk to him, dude”.

Then he walked away, leaving an angry Katsuki to his thoughts.

“Doesn’t the loneliness bother you?”

God. This shit again?!

“It never did”.

“I’m not asking about before. I’m asking about now”.

“I ain’t lonely”, he scoffed, rolling his eyes. “I finally have friends that aren’t just leeches feeding on my success. Shitty Hair, Dunce Face, Raccoon Eyes, Tape Guy, Ears…”, he trailed off.

A pause.

“I ain’t lonely”, he repeated for safe measure.

Silence.

“But there’s something missing”, Doctor Matsuo pointed out.

He didn’t confirm nor deny.

“Why don’t you try to make things right, like I suggested on your last session? if you feel like you were in the wrong when you fought?”

Katsuki scoffed.

“Because there’s no point. In the end, we’ll just end up fighting again, and again, and again. It’s better this way. If we keep our distance, if we –“

He paused. Doctor Matsuo said nothing.

“I can’t hurt him if I don’t talk to him”.

She blinked.

“That’s not the healthiest alternative”, she said, sounding almost amused.

“It’s not the easiest, either”.

Silence. He glared at her before looking away.

“Everyone keeps saying I don’t like things easy. And that’s right – I don’t. And it ain’t easy”, he shook his head. “*This* – Ain’t easy”.

He swallowed.

“But it’s for the best”.

She tilted her head. A few moments of silence passed.

“Have you ever heard about the Hedgehog’s Dilemma?”

Katsuki stared at her.

“The what?”

She adjusted her glasses.

“The Hedgehog’s Dilemma is an anecdote. It’s used by a lot of philosophers and psychanalysts when studying human intimacy”.

A pause.

“Basically, it’s about two hedgehogs in winter”, she sighed. “They need to cuddle to keep themselves warm, but the closer they get to one another, the more they are hurt by one another’s spines. However, if they keep themselves distanced, they suffer from the cold and could even freeze to death”.

Katsuki stared at her, a knowing look in his eyes.

“Do you understand why I’m telling you this?”, Doctor Matsuo asked.

“You think Deku and me are shitty hedgehogs”, he supplied in an unimpressed tone.

“It’s an analogy”, she explained, ignoring his sass. “For how humans work in a relationship. Being too far away hurts, but being too close hurts, too. What do you think would be a solution to that dilemma?”

Katsuki scoffed, annoyed, but thinking about it for a brief moment.

“Finding a middle ground”, he shrugged. “Not being too far as not to freeze, but not being too close as not to hurt each other”.

Not being friends, but not being enemies, either. Like his current situation with Deku.

Finding a middle ground, like Deku had proposed.

She nodded at him with an unimpressed look.

“Yes, that’s a good solution. But there are two things people don’t usually take into consideration when talking about the Hedgehog’s Dilemma”.

Katsuki frowned at her.

“One”, she continued, “is the hedgehog could cuddle with another animal for warmth – one that doesn’t have spines that hurt him and who has something to protect themselves from getting hurt by them. Like, say, a carapace. If the hedgehog cuddles with a turtle, both will be warm without hurting each other. A lot of people like to compare that with the human pursuit for diversity. That which we lack attracts us”.

She paused, giving Katsuki the space to comment. He didn’t.

“Two”, she resumed, giving Katsuki an unreadable look. “And this one is a lot more saying, is that, biologically speaking, a hedgehog’s spine can only hurt someone if they’re feeling afraid or stressed out. If they’re comfortable and relaxed, the spines aren’t as rigid, and they don’t really hurt”.

Katsuki swallowed dry.

“So, taking all of that into consideration”, she resumed. “Do you still think that isolating yourself from Midoriya-kun in order to avoid hurting him is the best idea? Or do you think that, maybe, you two are afraid, and that’s why you keep hurting each other?”

A pregnant pause.

“Because he’s hurt you, too”.

Katsuki scoffed, shaking his head.

“Not like I hurt him”.

“More hurt or less hurt – if he’s hurt you, then it doesn’t make a difference. Pain is not a competition, Katsuki”.

He was silent after that, not meeting her eyes.

"Do you long for his company?"

He frowned.

"What?"

"Do you enjoy being away for him? Or do you long for him?"

He scoffed, clicking his tongue and shaking his head in irritation.

"What does that have to do with anything?"

"Your desires matter".

"Yeah, but my desires keep fucking ruining everything for *everyone*. God, I miss the time I didn't care about this sort of shit", he ended up admitting.

"Why?", she asked, interested.

"Because then I could – I could just live my life and pursuit my goals without spending every fucking second worrying about how that'll affect some extras. I could just focus on myself and on what I wanted, instead of *constantly* focusing on everyone else. Instead of thinking about – *spines*, and winter, and shitty feelings all the time".

A pause. Doctor Matsuo adjusted her glasses again.

"Don't you think empathy is an important sentiment for a hero to have?"

"Not when it clouds their judgement, it isn't. Not when it gets in the way of their damn *reason*".

She nodded.

"Is that how you feel? Like your judgement is clouded?"

He scoffed.

"Don't try to turn this around, doc", he warned.

"That's not what I'm doing and you know it. Just answer the question, please".

He looked upwards, swallowing and scowling, before shaking his head at her again.

"I feel like *everything* is clouded. Like everything I used to know about myself has changed, and I can't recognize *me* anymore. I told Deku I wasn't going to change, I wasn't going to become someone else, but –", a dry scoff. "Didn't I? I mean, *why* do I care so much? And why do I care so much about *him*, specifically? Why can't I just bring myself to go back to not giving a shit and just doing as I please?"

“Why?”, she encouraged.

“I don’t fucking know!”, he ended up laughing humorlessly, his voice raising. “*You* tell me”.

“I think you’re close to figuring it out on your own”.

“You see, that’s the fucking problem –“, he gestured at her. “I don’t get why everything has to be so complicated. I don’t get why people would actually *choose* to go through this hellhole of confusing emotions instead of just sticking to *one* feeling and being done with it”.

She nodded patiently.

“So this is about your anger again”.

“I thought the *anger* was the damn point of this whole shitty therapy thing”, he scowled.

“We’ve already discussed this, Katsuki. And you had already come to terms with the fact that you’re more than just your anger”.

“Yeah? And why do I keep feeling it?”

A pause.

“Why does it keep burning inside me, why does it keep making me do things and say things that hurt other people? And why, in fuck’s name, do I *care* so much about it now?”

She studied him.

“Do you not like caring?”

“I fucking *hate* it”.

“Why?”

He took a deep breath, thinking about it with a grumpy expression.

“It makes my life harder. And not in a challenging way, or in a way that stimulates me or motivates me to outdo myself, otherwise I wouldn’t be whining about it. In a way that makes me feel sick”.

“Sick?”

“Yeah. With my stomach churning and shit. I actually feel fucking nauseous sometimes”.

“I see. And how else does it make you feel?”

“Dizzy”, he swallowed dry. “And sweaty, and – I don’t know, fucking tachycardic, with my heart racing for no reason. And sometimes, my face becomes numb, and it fucking *sucks*”.

She nodded again.

“And since when have you felt like that?”

“Ever since shitty Deku contaminated me with his touchy-feely shit and I stopped feeling just anger all the time”.

“We already established –“

“Yes, I *know* it wasn’t just anger. But it’s the only thing I knew how to feel, so let me have it”.

She leaned back against her chair.

“All right. And do all people make you feel like that?”

“What?”

“This feeling of nausea, and dizziness, and having your heart race. You said it comes from caring too much about people. Do all people make you feel like that? Or is it caused by specific people?”

Katsuki was silent. He simply stared at her, eyes narrowing in suspicion.

At a lack of a response, Doctor Matsuo leaned forwards, elbows taking support on her knees.

“Katsuki. Do you realize what I’m asking you?”

He swallowed.

“No”, he responded with honesty.

“Do you realize what these symptoms mean?”

He scoffed, nervous and confused, but trying to hide it behind a scowl.

“No”.

“Hm”, she hummed, leaning back on her seat and intertwining her fingers on her lap once more. “Do you have any idea what they could be?”

“I don’t fucking know”, he snapped, annoyed. Why was she asking him all that? “You’re the therapist, you’re the one supposed to be figuring this shit out”.

“I already have”.

He frowned.

“What the hell is that supposed to mean?”

“I’m trying to help you see. What do you think these symptoms mean?”

He scoffed, shrugging.

“I don’t know. I hate the thought of it, but if it’s – if it’s something like… *anxiety*, or stress, or some shit like that, I don’t know what to do about it, but I sure as hell don’t want anyone else to know. I don’t think I’m fucking anxious, by the way, but I’m just putting the symptoms together and that’s the most logical conclusion –“

“Katsuki”, she cut him off, serious.

“What?”, he asked, completely confused.

She sighed, removing her glasses. She looked conflicted, but determined, and the tone of her voice and the look in her eyes told Katsuki shit was about to get very real.

“Sharing a psychological diagnosis with a patient is not usually the most advisable course of action”, she started.

Katsuki frowned. Ok, so maybe it *was* anxiety? He recalled his first day back to class after he found out shitty Deku was glued to him, how he freaked out and lost it and blew up a chair and had to run away…

Since when have you had this?

T-This what, Kacchan?

This panicking shit. Anxiety, or whatever the hell you like to call it.

I – I don’t. I d-don’t have anxiety, Kacchan.

Fuck. Maybe Deku had been right. Maybe that had been Katsuki’s own anxiety all along. And if that was the case, he would have to get it treated, because he didn’t want this sort of –

“However”, Doctor Matsuo continued, breaking him away from his thoughts. “It’s not something *forbidden*, either, but a lot of professionals avoid it. In this case, however, I think it could be good for you”.

He stared at her, waiting. She stared back, serious.

“Diagnoses are rarely static. People can change, for the better or for worse, and so can their issues”, she explained. “Using labels – any sort of label – usually does more harm than good. I’ve already told you about how no one is only one thing. Restricting someone to their diagnosis, to their ‘label’, can do more harm than good”.

You’re a quirkless loser –

If you want to be a hero that badly, there’s a quick way to do it. Just pray that you’ll be born with a quirk on your next life and take a swan dive –

“But I think it’s important that you know that, in my professional opinion, you are traumatized by the events that have been taking place ever since you were kidnapped by the League of Villains”.

Katsuki stared at her, blinking, his train of thoughts coming to an abrupt halt.

He frowned.

What.

“I’m not fucking *trauma*–“

“Let me finish”, she cut him off with a subtle hand gesture, stern. “There is no shame in trauma, Katsuki. It’s a natural response. If it goes untreated, then yes, it can result in something more serious. But I’ve been trying my best to help you come to terms with everything that has been happening to you, so hopefully it won’t come to that, even though you *are* suffering from a level of anxiety as a result of your trauma”.

“What?”, his frown deepened, and now he was a mixture of confused and pissed. “You’ve been *manipulating* me?”

“Of *course* not”, she gave him a serious look. “And the only reason I’m telling you this is because I don’t believe these symptoms you just mentioned have anything to do with your trauma. *Or* with your anxiety”.

“Yeah”, he scoffed, angry. “Because I’m not traumatized, and this is just my body’s shitty reaction to caring so much about everything, now”.

She closed her eyes briefly.

“No, Katsuki”.

He squinted.

“What the hell are you on about?”

“If this is your body’s reacting to you caring for people”, she said patiently, “then why don’t you feel the same way about Kirishima, or Kaminari, or your other friends?”

Oh. So they were talking about Deku? Katsuki honestly had no fucking idea what was going on.

“Because they haven’t died over and over in front of me”, he shrugged, as if the answer was obvious. And when had it become obvious to him that he only felt sick and dizzy and numb whenever he was with Deku?

When had it become obvious to *her*?

She quirked an eyebrow at him.

“Is that it?”

“Yeah, that’s it”, Katsuki snapped, defensive. “What else would it be?!”

“Why don’t you take Kirishima dinner, or cook Kaminari his favorite dish, or lend either of them your notes?”

“Because they’re not *idiot losers* who almost died because they took a damn blow in my place! Because they didn’t spend months in a hospital bed and because they didn’t get so sick they had to skip class, and because they don’t *need* me to!”

Doctor Matsuo offered him a sad smile.

“So are you saying Midoriya needs you?”

“Damn well he does!”

Midoriya shonen needs you. More than ever.

“And do you need him in return?”

And something tells me that you need him, too.

He scoffed, choking on his response. Suddenly, he felt very defensive about this conversation – and although Doctor Matsuo seemed to know almost everything there was to know about him, losing only for Deku when it came to “Who Knows Katsuki the Best”, he didn’t want to be so vulnerable to the point of admitting he *needed* Deku. Even if he knew Doctor Matsuo was well aware of that. He didn’t want her to use that against him – he didn’t want to prove her right.

It was childish, he knew. But he hadn’t expected he would feel so cornered about this subject, and thus he hadn’t prepared himself for it.

“I – What? No, I – I don’t need him”, he scoffed. “If I needed him, I wouldn’t have spent the past months giving him the cold shoulder”.

The excuse sounded weak to his own ears.

Weak.

“Are you sure it was you giving him the cold shoulder, and not the other way around?”

Katsuki scoffed again.

“We were *both* giving each other the cold shoulder”.

“Yes. And that upsets you”.

“No, it doesn’t”, he lied. “I told you, I would have that whole fight with him again if it came down to it”.

“Having the courage to do it again doesn’t mean it doesn’t upset you”.

“Well, it *doesn’t*”.

“Really? Because you seem to be very focused on this subject”.

“Are you *kidding* me? You’re gonna throw this shit on my face, now?”

“Katsuki, that’s not what I’m doing”, she told him patiently, looking almost incredulous. “I’m just trying to make you see”.

“Make me see what?”

“That the way you care for Midoriya is different from the way you care for your other friends. And that forcing yourself to be away from him, even if you long to be close to him, is hurting you, and probably him, too”.

He scowled.

“Yeah, the way I care for him is different because he’s the one who died in front of me. I’m forcing myself to be away from him because he *told* me he wants me to. I’m not about to impose my presence on him against his will; I’m not about to *humiliate* myself when he wants nothing to do with me”.

“What do you mean, humiliate yourself?”, she frowned.

“Well? What would you call running after him and licking his boots just so he can have the pleasure of kicking me away? I’m not about to fucking do it. Not with him, not with *anyone*”.

“Why would he kick you away?”, her frown deepened.

“He fucking told me he doesn’t want me to –“

“Okay”, she interrupted him. “Allow me to reformulate. Why would he take *pleasure* in kicking you away?”

Katsuki was silent, mouth opening and closed as he sought a response.

Doctor Matsuo stared at him, waiting.

He came up empty.

“I – I don’t know”.

“I see”.

“I just”, he shook his head slightly, shrugging as he tried to put his feelings into words. “It’s just how I’ve felt my whole life. There went Deku, the pathetic fucking loser, parading around like he was the fucking best, looking down on me, offering me his help even though I didn’t fucking need it. Acting like he was better, and superior, even though he wasn’t. Acting like he could surpass me, and – he shouldn’t have been able to”.

Doctor Matsuo nodded silently.

“And – we’ve already been through that, and – he explained, and I understood, that he didn’t look down on me. That he admired me. But why else would he do that shit unless he was fucking messing with me? Why would he pretend he was ok with how I acted for months, and then out of the fucking blue decide he couldn’t stand it anymore? Why the hell would he do all that unless he was taking a piss at me? Unless he wanted to humiliate me, like I always thought he was doing?”

His therapist watched him in silence, face neutral.

“Maybe he realized something, over the course of those months, that made him change his mind”.

“*What* could he have realized?”, Katsuki protested.

She gave him a sad look.

“I don’t know. That is for him to say”.

He scoffed, looking away.

“Very helpful”.

“Katsuki”, she called.

He met her eyes, glaring.

She bit her lower lip, looking conflicted.

“You won’t know unless you ask him”, she shook her head. “You haven’t told me all the details of this fight, and you don’t have to do that unless you want to. But maybe – *maybe* he reacted like that because he feels as confused as you are feeling”.

He narrowed his eyes.

“Maybe the fact that you’re nice to him in some stances and harsh in others is giving him mixed signals. Maybe just *telling* him you care isn’t enough. Maybe he’s feeling as lost as you are. I can’t tell what he’s feeling or thinking. Neither can you. The only person who can do that is Midoriya-kun. Trying to guess is a terrible option, and you won’t know the truth unless you sit down with him and discuss it. If you keep pushing him away, you’ll both just…”, she shook her head. “Freeze in winter weather”.

He clicked his tongue, looking away.

“That analogy is shit”.

“But it works”, she retorted. “Because maybe Midoriya-kun is also a hedgehog, who’s feeling just as scared as you are, and maybe that’s why you keep hurting each other. Maybe this whole situation can be solved if you two simply…”, she let out a sigh and shrugged simply. “Lower your defenses and trust each other a little more”.

He stared at her.

“You spent your whole life being defensive towards him, since you assumed that he looked down on you and decided to attack him as way to protect yourself, and your ego. In return, he spent his whole life being defensive towards you, even if he still admired you. You both seem to be afraid that the person you spent so long believing each other to be is the true version of yourselves. Don’t you think it’s time to break away from that cycle?”

Katsuki was silent.

He didn’t know what to say to that, so he looked away, eyes trailing the carpet as he thought about her words.

“Listen”, she said patiently. “Our time is up for today, but I’d like it very much if you thought about our conversation”.

“You want me to think about the hedgehog shit?”, he looked at her with an impatient expression.

“Katsuki”.

“*Fine*. I’ll think about it”, he rolled his eyes, grumpy.

“Good. We can resume this talk on our next session, all right?”

He sighed, running a hand across his face.

“Yeah, I forgot to tell you about that. I think we’ll have to reschedule the next session. Next week that shitty hero museum everyone’s been talking about is opening, and I promised the tech chick I’d go and vote for her gadgets. You know, as a pay-up for all the work she put on my hearing aid and all that”.

“Sure, that’s fine”, Doctor Matsuo nodded, comprehensive. “I’ll have to get back to you later about how we can reschedule your appointment, but I’ll text you about it as soon as I have a date and time. Is that ok?”

“Yeah, it’s fine”, he stood up, grabbing his backpack.

“Are your friends going with you to the museum with you?”, she asked politely as she stood up as well, ready to see him out.

“Yeah”, he sighed. “They’re way too eager about it. Wouldn’t shut up all weekend”.

She smiled fondly at him, opening the door.

“Well, you go and have some fun with them, then. I hope you have a nice time”.

“I doubt it”.

He scoffed humorously before reaching out and holding his forearm with gentleness.

“Katsuki”, she said before he could rush out of the room. He turned to look at her, backpack thrown over only one of his shoulders. “Don’t forget to think about what I told you”.

He rolled his eyes again. She continued to stare at him, waiting for an answer.

“Yeah, fine”, he complied.

She smiled.

“See you next week”.

“See ya”.

“Ah! Midoriya, Todoroki! Hi!”

“Bakugou. Kirishima”.

“Oh! Hi, K-Kirishima-kun! Hi, uh, Kacchan…”

Katsuki didn’t look at Deku or at Icy Hot when their sweaty forms walked past him and Kirishima at the entrance of the gym. Instead, he simply kept on walking, hands tightened into fists, while Kirishima lingered behind with an apologetic look on his face. Katsuki didn’t bother looking back at them – he simply waited for Kirishima to be done with whatever shitty social interaction he was having and come to their training already.

If this had happened a year before, he would have kicked Shitty Hair’s ass into the afterlife during their training as a way to cope with the bitterness, but now? Now, he trained just as he would in any other day, *not* taking his frustration out on his best friend and *not* overpowering his blows with resentment.

He kept his anger – and his other shitty emotions – at bay, focusing on what he needed to do: beat Kirishima without overdoing it. The best key to that was *not* thinking about what moves Icy Hot must have used on Deku, or about their chests pressed together, or about him pinning Deku to the floor, with his hands on his wrists, with his ass on his crotch, with that stupid Half’n’Half mouth of his breathing all over Deku’s face and neck as they panted at each other.

(He very pointedly did *not* think about what Doctor Matsuo asked him, either, but that was a whole different, unrelated story).

Once they decided they were done training for the day, Katsuki went back to his room after bidding his best friend a short goodbye.

He never learned if Deku had liked his birthday present or not. The nerd never mentioned it, and Katsuki never asked. The only interactions they had had after that were short, purely social “good morning”s, “good evening”s, “can you pass me that, please?”s and variations thereof.

But Deku still called him Kacchan, instead of Katsuki or – god forbid – Bakugou. So maybe all hope wasn’t lost.

(Katsuki didn’t know what he would do if Deku ever dropped that stupid childhood nickname. Maybe the universe would collapse or some shit. Other than anger and loneliness, that was the only constant he had left – the only thin, weak thread of hope still connecting him to Deku, in a way.)

Of course that pink-haired tech chick would want him to show up for the *first* goddamn day of the museum’s opening. Of *course* the shitty voting she wanted him to take part in would be on the first goddamn day.

And of course the motherfucking museum would be crowded and overflowing with losers who didn’t have anything better to do with their spare time.

Apart from the other hundred people there, walking around so close together it made the place look like in an ant nest, some of these losers with nothing better to do included: Katsuki, Kirishima, Kaminari, Mina, Sero, Jirou, and Yaoyorozu.

With the sole exception of Katsuki, all of them had been *dying* to go to this shitty expo ever since they first heard the announcement about it. They had been lucky to buy their tickets on the first lot, because after that the demand for it skyrocketed – as did the prices. Apparently, the first day of the exposition would include exclusive panels and speeches that wouldn't happen again, which meant *everybody* wanted to attend on that day.

Katsuki realized, with a bittersweet feeling, just how much had changed in his life ever since he heard that shit about the museum for the first time. It felt like a lifetime had passed.

Ohh, Bakugou, you know how it is. One person tells another, and next thing you know the whole school is discussing whether they'll go or not. I'm pretty sure I'll go, if I can! It sounds like fun, and from what I've heard there will be contests and meet & greets with some heroes!

Will Crimson Riot be there?

Ok, calm down, fanboy.

They haven't announced which heroes will be there yet –

Maybe there will be none and this is all just a marketing strategy to lure people into a museum.

Why would anyone want to lure people into a museum?

Uh, because no one would go in otherwise?

Fuck, Katsuki wished his shitty friends' assumption had been right. At least that would mean the place wouldn't be overflowing with extras.

As it turned out, there was no meet & greet, either – this had just been one of the many bent truths people spread and gossiped about with no actual reliable source. Which made Kirishima particularly disappointed, since he'd been *dying* to take a picture with Crimson Riot.

Bakugou, on the other hand, was thankful as fuck about this spread of apparent misinformation. If the place was already crowded with no meet & greet, he didn't even want to *fathom* what it would look like had famous heroes been in there, willing to take pictures with the extras. He couldn't walk for a meter without being bumped by some rando, which was *not* doing wonders to his already sour mood – if the place had been even more crowded, he would have told Hatsume to shove it and howitzer-impacto himself out of there.

(He wouldn't actually do that, not after all the time and effort she put on his aids. But he *would* be pretty pissed – even more than he currently was.)

Almost a year of anger management therapy was being deleted from Katsuki's brain little by little with each shoulder that bumped into his while he made his way to the auditorium. There would be a shitty opening speech there soon, and for some god forsaken reason the assholes who organized the event decided to put the fucking *All Might expo* on the same floor as the auditorium – meaning the whole floor was fucking crowded.

Remembering Doctor Matsuo's advices was getting harder and harder, and he almost lost his shit completely when a random loser stepped on his foot. The guy apologized frantically, especially after he noticed the way Katsuki's nostrils were flaring, but Kirishima forced his best friend to keep walking before the situation could escalate into a scene.

Quite frankly, this was the last place on Earth Katsuki wanted to be at. It was too crowded, too noisy, too annoying. There was nothing to do there but see and take pictures with wax statues of famous heroes (not interested), watch boring lectures about shit he already knew all about (not interested), and attend to that (probably boring) gadget competition so that he could vote for Support Girl and be done with his promise.

(At least he was trying to keep this one.)

She had *really* put a lot of time and effort into building him a hearing aid that: didn't hurt; was small, light, and easy to maneuver; didn't get feedback from his explosion quirk; was still functional when he played the drums; and blended perfectly with his skin tone. He knew it mustn't have been easy – every time she delivered him a new version, he came up with a new demand, and the aid needed to be re-updated. And even if she seemed to *enjoy* doing these things for him and pushing herself harder (since her invention could also help other heroes who suffered from hearing disabilities in the future, which would make her a pioneer in the area), Katsuki was still well aware of how much backbone she had put into this. And he never even did anything in return other than saying "thanks".

So yeah. The least he could do was endure a few hours of this hell and vote for her stupid gadgets in the contest – and make sure his stupid friends did the same, too.

Hatsume deserved to win, after all. She was pretty fucking good.

Katsuki almost let himself sigh in relief as he entered the auditorium and found that it was *not* crowded, which he was immensely thankful for. The fact that the opening speech would only start in three hours and that the queue of people wanting to take pictures with All Might's wax statue was already kilometric had probably been the cause of that.

For some reason, those asshole organizers had decided that everything All Might-related would also be short-lived in the museum – his expo, his statues, his exclusive graphic books, his merch: all that would only be available during the first weekend after the museum's opening. Which meant the *ridiculous* number of people inside that shitty eleven-story building was very, very high.

Katsuki had a weird feeling about this, if he had to be honest. He didn't really see the reason why a brand-new museum, whose building had been raised from the ground up *just* to host an ongoing exposition about heroes, would make such nonsensical limitations. All Might was Japan's greatest hero of all time, there was no doubt about that, so it didn't quite add up to make his exhibition on a fucking *Hero-focused* museum last for only two days. It felt almost like the people who came up with this shit had been trying to concentrate every possible guest that would be interested on the shitty museum there, on the same day.

Katsuki shook his head, swatting the thought away. He was starting to sound like a paranoid nutcase. He wouldn't go as far as Doctor Matsuo and say he was *traumatized*, because he

didn't do trauma, but he could acknowledge he was creating a pattern of being overly-suspicious of things that didn't present any incoming danger, like when he freaked out over his friends acting weird on the way to the park or…

Or the shitshow that happened afterwards.

So instead of complaining or sharing his suspicions with someone else, Katsuki simply took a seat on the place he deemed the easiest to escape from should he need to: his chair was right beside the auditorium's corridor, next to an emergency exit, and also next to a large window. If he needed to go to the bathroom, he wouldn't have to call attention by excusing himself for a bunch of extras who happened to be on the way, and the same was true if he found the speech boring and just wanted to skedaddle. If everything went to shit and there was some sort of attack, he'd be at a strategical spot to aid people away through the emergency exit, *and* to jump at the villain by surprise from the flank. If everyone managed to escape except for him, he could jump out of the window, even if the auditorium was situated in the 11th floor of the building – he could use his explosions to lower himself down. Strategically speaking, this was the best possible seat he could take on the auditorium – there was no denying that.

"Bakugouuu", Mina whined mournfully as he sat down. "We won't be able to see *anything* from here!"

Katsuki rolled his eyes. Of *course* his shitty friends would complain about his choice.

"It's too far back, man", Kaminari added to Mina's wailing, taking the seat beside Katsuki and throwing an arm behind his shoulders, pulling him into a sideways hug. "See?", he craned his neck, trying to take a look at the small stage far at the front of the auditorium. "The place is empty and I already can't see anything. Just imagine what it will be like when all those people out there take the seats in front of us".

"We should take the opportunity that there are lots of seats to choose from and take the ones in the *front*!", Mina added, bouncing on the balls of her feet anxiously. Katsuki scoffed and rolled his eyes.

"Tch. If you losers want to take the seats in the front, be my fucking guests. I'm staying here".

"We won't leave you here all by yourself, Bakugou!", Mina protested.

"Yeah, man", Kirishima approached him, nudging at his shoulder. "C'mon. It wouldn't be nice of us to leave you all alone here at the back. Come sit with us!"

Katsuki glared at Kirishima.

"I don't want to sit at the damn front", he said through gritted teeth. He ended up sounding like a spoiled brat, but he didn't care. Kirishima clearly didn't understand his reasons for sitting there and he wasn't about to justify himself.

“*Bakugouuuuuu*”, Mina whined again, the last vowels of his name getting dragged longer every time she called him. “Come *on*! This is a one-time-only kind of event! The type of thing we’ll tell our grandchildren about!”

“*Haah*?”, he scowled. “You’re thinking way too much of this shitty museum”.

“Don’t be like that”, Sero reprehended. “The museum is kind of a big deal”, he shrugged.

“Look”, Jirou stepped into the conversation, nudging her foot at Kaminari’s leg until he yielded and got up from his seat. Once he did, she occupied his place beside Katsuki. “You guys go sit at the front. I’ll stay back here with Blasty and Momo”.

Yaoyorozu gave her a puzzled look before complying and taking the seat beside her friend.

“But Jirou-san!”, Mina protested, still sounding too whiny for Katsuki’s liking. “We don’t want the group to be separated!”

“It will be fine, guys”, Jirou told them. “I don’t really want to sit too close to the front, either. All the sound equipment is there; I wouldn’t want to cause another feedback accident like… you know”, she shrugged, not looking at Katsuki.

“This way, Bakugou-kun won’t be on his own”, Yaoyorozu supported her, a soft smile on her lips. “And we won’t risk ruining the presentation”.

“But who’s gonna watch our bags while we’re gone?”, Kaminari lamented, earning a harsh nudge of Mina’s elbow on his side.

“Haah?”, Katsuki scowled again. “That’s why you losers wanted us to go sit there? So we can watch your shitty bags for you?!”

“No, no, no, of course not!”, Kaminari shook his hands and his head.

“Never mind, guys, he’s just being an idiot”, Mina smiled awkwardly. “We’ll leave the bags there to mark our seats and go take some pics outside. And no one will steal them because this is a *hero convention*”, she said the words emphatically, glaring at Kaminari.

“But you said –!”, Kaminari tried to protest, but Mina grabbed his arm, squeezing hard.

“We’ll be right back, guys!”, she announced as cheerfully as always, leading a confused Kaminari away. Sero and Kirishima followed them, waving Katsuki, Jirou, and Yaoyorozu goodbye.

“Tch”, Katsuki scoffed as their friends left their bags on the damn front row and walked past them again, chatting loudly and heading out the auditorium.

“This place will be crowded in a couple of hours”, Jirou commented, looking around.

There were only a few people sitting inside the auditorium, probably meaning to mark their seats as well. The place seemed to have a capacity of hundreds of people – or it *needed* to have, given that the number of guests outside seemed to be nearing that.

“I don’t see why”, Katsuki commented, grumpy, fishing his phone out of his pocket and idly checking his social media. He never posted anything, but he liked to keep track with local newspapers and world news. “It’s not like attendance is mandatory, and there’s *way* more interesting shit to do outside”.

“Well, attendance would be common courtesy”, Yaoyorozu pointed out. “This is the first day of the museum’s opening. The speech won’t be delivered on any other day of the exhibit. They will probably pause the other expositions outside as a way to motivate people to come in here. Maybe they’ve even invited someone famous to deliver the speech”.

“Yeah, maybe a top-ten hero or something. And they’re also handing out special All Might souvenirs afterwards, so…”, Jirou added, shrugging. “I’m pretty sure a lot of people out there will be coming in here in no time”.

Something about that didn’t sit right with Katsuki and he frowned. Why would they fucking hand over All Might souvenirs to a bunch of random people – hundreds, actually? That *had* to be expensive. Why were they so interested in forcing people to watch this shitty speech? What was so special about it?

His stream of suspicious thoughts was interrupted as he swapped his thumb up and down on his phone screen, rushing by a lot of posts that didn’t interest him enough – until he found one that did.

It was another picture posted by Round Face, showing her, Class Rep, Icy Hot, and shitty Deku, just outside at the All Might expo. They were standing at the over-crowded queue of people waiting to take a picture with All Might’s wax statue, which could be seen behind them, far back at the distance.

Katsuki scowled.

They looked happy. Even Icy Hot was smiling a bit.

He knew Deku was bound to come to this shitty museum on the opening day, no matter how crowded or uncomfortable it could turn out to be. And Katsuki was no longer in a position to give the shitty nerd his two cents and tell him this was a bad fucking idea for his recovering body – too many people, too many germs, too many *risks*.

But what he hadn’t expected was that shitty fucking Deku would actually be stupid enough to stand in a crowded queue for hours just to take a picture with a fucking All Might wax statue.

The motherfucker was literally All Might’s heir. He could take as many pictures in as many poses as he wanted with All fucking Might. God; he could take an accidental selfie with the guy while they ate lunch and that would *still* be a hundred times more exclusive than a shitty photo with a generic wax statue.

Katsuki was pretty sure Deku would be the fucking death of him. How was it possible for someone to be so stupid, so reckless, so uncaring for their own well-being?! Idiot. *Asshole.*

But… He did look happy. His smile was wide enough to make his dimples appear on his cheeks, and his green eyes were sparkling with life and excitedness. He was also wearing an All Might shirt, Katsuki noticed.

The All Might shirt. The one Katsuki had given him for his birthday. The one Deku never talked about or thanked him for.

He didn't know how to feel about that.

Katsuki sighed and scrolled past the photo without liking it.

"Is that why you didn't want to sit at the front?", Jirou asked, a curious tone in her voice.

Katsuki turned to look at her – Yaoyorozu was gone, her small, expensive backpack resting on her seat to mark her place. And Ears had her eyes glued to the screen of Katsuki's phone, before they darted upwards to meet his gaze.

Angry, he locked the phone and shoved it back into his pocket, feeling like he had just been caught red-handed doing something forbidden.

"That's fucking *rude*", he scolded her. "*And* intrusive".

"Yeah", she shrugged, apologetic. "I know, sorry about that. I didn't mean to pry, really, but you were glaring at your phone so hard I got curious as to what it was about".

He scoffed, not looking at her as he crossed his arms above his chest.

"Where's your friend?", he asked bitterly.

"Out to get us something to eat. And she's your friend, too", Jirou raised an eyebrow at him.

"Didn't think we could eat in here", he commented absentmindedly.

"There are no signs at the door saying we can't. And you're dodging the question".

He turned his head to glare at her. She stared back, unfaltering.

"Is that why you didn't want to sit at the front?", she repeated herself, quirking her eyebrows. Katsuki scowled.

"I don't know what the hell you're talking about".

"Midoriya", she responded simply.

He didn't know why the name felt like a punch to his gut. He didn't know why his heart immediately felt tight inside his chest, or why his face and hands went cold, or why his stomach felt like it had suddenly decided to hate his breakfast. Instead of trying to figure it out, he simply deepened his scowl, staring straight ahead and not meeting Ear's eyes.

“If what I picked from him during the time we’ve known each other is right, he seems like the kind of guy who’d sit at the front in an event like this”, she shrugged when Katsuki didn’t say anything.

He continued to stare straight ahead, in silence.

“So I assumed that was why”, she concluded.

He wondered about what she was telling him. Could it be? Had he subconsciously avoided sitting at the front so that he could, at the same time, avoid sitting next to shitty Deku? Because he had known him for longer than Ears did, he had known him *his whole life,* and thus he knew that was exactly where the nerd would sit? Could this have been his mind acting faster than he could catch up; his brain trying to preserve him without him really realizing?

Nah. Thinking about it, he hadn’t even considered shitty Deku’s presence when he chose his seat. All he had thought about was an attack plan – an escape plan. He had been seeking the most strategical seat in the room so that he could have advantage in battle should the need arise – so that he could have advantage in aiding an *escape* should the need arise.

This, for once, wasn’t about Deku – it was about what he could do to prevent catastrophe in case everything went wrong.

“No”, he said sharply, simply, but with confidence. Jirou nodded her head in silence, also staring straight ahead.

“And have you spoken to him?”, she asked, and Katsuki immediately sighed.

Seriously? Couldn’t she just fucking drop it for once in her shitty life? Couldn’t any of his friends? What was it about Katsuki’s face that made people look at him and immediately decide to talk to him about the *one fucking subject* he didn’t want to discuss?

“Ears –“, he started impatiently.

“Bakugou. I’m not trying to force you into talking about this”, she cut him off before he could get started, apparently reading his mind. She was looking at him, and he returned the favor – only a bit more angrily than her. “I just want to know if you *really* haven’t spoken to him at all ever since your birthday. Because, if that’s the case, then it’s been six months”.

“Yeah. And what is it to you?”, he retorted, annoyed at her nosiness.

“Nothing. But it’s something to you”, she commented, defensive.

Then, just as quickly, she deflated, shaking her head in disapproval.

“I don’t know. I guess I’m just worried”, she shrugged.

“There’s nothing to worry about”, he scoffed, looking away again. “It was bound to happen, sooner or later”.

A pause. She stared at him with a weird look on her face.

“What do you mean?”

Katsuki shrugged.

“This fight. This whole shit. I knew we wouldn’t be able to keep playing friends for too long”.

A pause.

“And I don’t want to fucking talk about it”.

Jirou opened her mouth as if she wanted to discuss it, but then she decided against it and let her lips close once more. She looked away, pensive, crossing her arms above her chest in a way similar to Katsuki and bouncing her leg up and down.

It took her a while to speak up again.

“I don’t know”, she commented, sounding hesitant. “I mean, we don’t *have* to talk about it. I’ll stop insisting”, she shrugged. “But I don’t think that’s true”.

Katsuki stared at her.

“I think you two found a way to get along just fine when he… Well”, she sighed. “When he was a ghost. I mean, there was no way out, was there? You *had* to talk to each other. You couldn’t just ignore each other for months, like you’re doing now. Maybe that’s what making a difference here”.

Katsuki scoffed, looking straight ahead with a scowl.

“I can’t force him into talking to me, now. He was very clear about this. He doesn’t want me to”.

“He *didn’t* want you to”, Jirou corrected. “Back then, at the heat of the moment. He was upset. I only have a vague idea what happened and you don’t have to tell me about it, but I’m pretty sure, as is everyone else, that if you tried talking to him now, he would listen to what you have to say”.

Katsuki sighed.

“And what do *I* have to say?”, he asked, bitter and annoyed. “That I’m sorry?”

“That’d be a nice start, yes”, she nodded, shrugging again and seeming surprised at Katsuki’s apparent reluctance.

“And what if I’m not? Hm?”, he glared at her. “What if I don’t regret it?”

She studied his face.

“I didn’t know what the hell was happening. I thought it was another villain attack”, he shook his head. “And the idiot wanted to jump right at it, even though he was recovering from a fucking fever, high on anti-allergics, and with the physical strength of a chicken who caught the flu. He was about to get himself killed all over again, and I wasn’t about to let him. So I did what I had to do”, he scoffed. “And I would do it again if it came down to it”.

Jirou bit her lower lip, serious and pensive. Eventually, she nodded.

“I understand”.

Katsuki scoffed.

“Right”.

“I really do. I mean, I do, now”, she said. “I’m guessing you pushed him and told him something horrible to force him to step back. And – well. I get *why* you did it”.

Katsuki looked at her.

“But I don’t think he does”, she continued, giving him an apologetic headshake. “I don’t think he understands how much you care”.

Katsuki groaned, throwing his head back in impatience.

Was he really in the position to deny that shit anymore? Hadn’t he humiliatingly made it clear, over and over again, that he cared about Deku? That he worried about him? That he didn’t want to see the asshole fucking *die* in front of him again?

“And that’s why you should tell him”, Jirou concluded.

He sighed, more loudly than he needed to.

“I *told* him”, he protested, angry. “Before all that shitshow went down. I told him I cared. More than once. But he just fucking ignored that; he complained about my words not matching my actions and shit. Complained about me being rude, as if I haven’t *always* been fucking rude my entire goddamn life. As if I haven’t done way worse shit to him”.

Jirou gave him a sad look.

“Bakugou, just because you’ve done worse things –“

Before she could finish, Yaoyorozu returned, three paper bags on her hands.

“Hi”, she greeted gently, smiling, and then she handed one bag to Jirou, one to Katsuki, and kept the third one. “Ah, Bakugou-kun. I’m sorry, I didn’t know what you would like, so I just picked the spiciest food they had”, she shrugged at him.

“That’s fine”, Katsuki said simply, taking a peek inside his bag.

He wasn't really hungry, and he definitely didn't feel like eating, but they were just having a talk about being rude and he wasn't about to throw the bag back at Yaoyorozu's face. Even if it was to prove that he was trying to be better.

"Did I interrupt you two?", Yaoyorozu frowned, noticing how the atmosphere had grown tense after her arrival. "Because… I can –"

"You didn't", Katsuki said, just as Jirou opened her mouth to say something. Both girls turned to look at him. "We were done talking", he added, giving Jirou a pointed look.

The girls snapped her mouth shut in disapproval, but nodded.

"Yeah. Yeah, it's ok, Momo", Jirou said, offering a smile to her friend. "Thank you for getting us something to eat".

"Ah, it was no trouble. It's still going to be a while until the presentation starts, right? I figured it would be better if we didn't wait on an empty belly", she blushed slightly, smiling and shrugging simplistically.

Jirou went back to talking to Yaoyorozu about whatever they had been talking about before the girl went out to buy their snacks, but not a minute after her return, Katsuki felt his phone vibrate inside his pocket. He fished it out and opened his new message.

From: Ears

I figured you wouldn't want to talk about this with her here. But we can definitely keep talking later, ok?

From: Ears

It's like I said, I'm here for you. And I'm willing to listen.

From: Ears

After all, I'm all ears.

From: Ears

Wink wink

Katsuki rolled his eyes, but there was affection in the gesture.

From: Bakugou

That was cheesy as fuck

He set the phone away and resumed eating his snack. It was nowhere near spicy enough, but he never told Yaoyorozu that.

He knew Ears wasn't exactly wrong. He and Deku *had* gotten along fine when they were stuck together and forced to talk to each other. But he couldn't exactly lock himself with the nerd on a broom closet and only let him out after they fucking talked, could he? That'd be fucked up, and Katsuki didn't even know why he imagined that scenario in the first place.

Maybe what was making a difference was that Katsuki and Izuku couldn't share their feelings anymore. Before, while Izuku was a ghost, they had both been hedgehogs – but even if they hurt each other, they could also share the pain, and the warmth, and the cold, and the happiness.

Now, all they ever did was hurt each other. No more sharing. No more understanding without using words, no more empathy. No more synchrony. And Katsuki didn't know how to make it right, because words didn't seem to suffice, and he knew they couldn't ever, *ever* go back to the kind of bond they had shared during that one month.

He just didn't know what to do, and he hated the feeling. He had *always* hated that feeling. A smothered part of himself wanted to just walk up to Deku at that shitty All Might queue, scream everything he was thinking and feeling at his face, and be done with it. But he decided against it.

Maybe he was a weak coward after all.

His hands left scorched prints on the paper bag Yaoyorozu had given him, and his mood grew even more sour than it had been before.

Half an hour before the opening speech began, a crew entered the auditorium to test the lighting and the sound.

The place was now filled with a lot more people than it had been when Katsuki had first arrived there, but it was nowhere near full capacity yet. His dumbass friends had already returned from whatever shitty strolling they had gone off to, and now Mina, Sero, Kaminari, and Kirishima were sitting far away from them, on the first row. Other students from Class 1-A and from UA were there as well, along with a bunch of extras Katsuki had never seen in his life.

He had been distracting himself with some articles on his phone while Jirou and Yaoyorozu chatted excitedly beside him, and therefore he nearly jumped out of his damn skin when a loud-as-fuck noise exploded from his left out of nowhere.

His first instinct was to duck to the side and cover his ears, and once he regained enough of his balance, he saw that Yaoyorozu, as well as some people sitting near them, had done the same. The only one who wasn't doing it was Ears – and then Katsuki realized that it was because *she* was the one who had made that noise.

She was blushing so hard her face looked like a tomato, and as a couple men from the sound tech team approached them, she began to stutter.

"I – I don't – I d-don't know w-what happened, I'm sorry, m-my quirk usually doesn't – it doesn't act up like this, s-sorry", she struggled to say the words, her face bright red from embarrassment.

Yaoyorozu rubbed at her ears in discomfort and so did Katsuki – and as he did so, it became clearer than ever why he was there at that shitty expo in the first place. If it hadn't been for Hatsume's improved hearing aid, the feedback from Jirou's quirk would have probably sent him fucking insane.

"Don't worry, that's fine", one of the tech men told Jirou with a sympathetic smile. "It's all right, everyone; this was just a technical issue", he turned around to reassure the rest of the auditorium, who were all staring at Jirou with variations of fright, annoyance, and confusion. From the distance, Katsuki could see their friends watching with a worried look.

"I'm really sorry", Jirou said again, lowering her head in embarrassment. "I – I don't know why this happened, I sat back here precisely to avoid causing feedback –"

"It's ok", Yaoyorozu reassured her, grabbing her hand and offering her a smile.

"Yes, your friend is right", the man smiled at her again. "This wasn't your fault. But… Well…", he hesitated, scratching the back of his head and actually looking embarrassed. "I hate to say this, but I'm afraid we can't let this happen again during the event".

Jirou's blush became even more intense, if that was possible, and she started to get up, grabbing her backpack.

"Oh – O-Oh, yes, of course, I understand", he said, apologetic, and Katsuki frowned.

"Oi, Ears, where do you think you're going?", he demanded, grabbing the hem of her shirt as if to keep her in place.

"Oh, don't worry, I'll – I'll just wait outside and meet you guys when –"

"Oh, no, no, no, please, don't", the man gestured at her before she could continue, looking embarrassed and nervous. "Please, by no means, I wasn't kicking you out of here", he chuckled awkwardly.

Jirou stayed where she was, half-standing and half-sitting, her eyes darting between the man, Katsuki, and Yaoyorozu and one hand holding the strap of her backpack, which had been thrown over her shoulder.

“B-But… I don’t know if this will happen again, during the speech, and I don’t want to –“, she frowned, confused.

“Don’t worry about that”, he chuckled, gesturing at the other sound tech guy who was standing at the distance and indicating for him to approach them. “I have a sound quirk myself; I know how it can be. That’s why we use these”, he extended his arm to Jirou so that she could see his wristband. As the other guy approached them, Katsuki realized he was wearing the same device. “It temporarily changes the frequency of your quirk so it can’t interfere with nearby sound equipment. It’s pretty useful, especially if you have to work with this kind of thing all day long”, he smiled at her.

“Oh”, she blinked. “T-That’s… Interesting. I’d never seen that before”, she stared at the wristband with curiosity, the hint of a frown appearing on her brow.

“Yes, it’s brand-new technology. It isn’t on the market yet. But… How about this?”, he scratched the back of his head again. “I think we may have a spare one back at the deposit. You won’t need to miss the presentation if you wear it; we could lend you the spare one and you could give it back to us once the speech is over”.

“Ah, that’s a great idea!”, Yaoyorozu smiled happily at Jirou. “But… Um. Can I see it?”

The man frowned at her, tilting his head to the side.

“It’s – well, my quirk”, Yaoyorozu explained awkwardly. “I can create things. Maybe if I take a good look at it and figure out how it works, I can recreate it! This way, you won’t have to go through the trouble of going back to the deposit just to find her the spare one. I’m sure you two are busy enough as it is”, she smiled, gentle.

The men stared at her with blank expressions.

“But – we will discard it once we’re done, of course”, she reassured the men with a nervous chuckle when they didn’t respond, assuming that was the reason for their reluctance. “Kyouka can buy a proper one when they are for sale. I wouldn’t want to – um. Disrupt the market”.

The first man opened and closed his mouth, clearly taken aback by everything Yaoyorozu was saying. He exchanged a look with his colleague, hesitant.

“Actually”, the second man – the one who arrived later – stepped in. “We can’t remove ours for you to look at, or it could cause an even worse feedback. And we’re already on a tight schedule, here”.

“Yeah”, the first man nodded emphatically. “Yeah, we’re on a really tight schedule, and we need to sort out the sound equipment as fast as we can. I think it’ll be faster if you just go grab the spare one”, he smiled.

“Okay”, Jirou nodded promptly, removing her backpack and placing it on her seat as if to mark it, even though Katsuki and Yaoyorozu were there to save it for her. She looked eager to just sort out that embarrassing misunderstanding and remove herself from the spotlight in which she had accidentally ended up. She offered her friends a tight smile. “I’ll be right back, guys”, she announced.

“All right”, Yaoyorozu answered, whereas Katsuki simply stared at her with a serious expression. Jirou walked out of the auditorium, led by the second sound tech guy.

The other one cleared his throat awkwardly.

“Well, I should get back to checking the sound”, he said with another embarrassed smile. Katsuki realized he found the gesture kind of annoying, but he couldn’t really tell why.

Yaoyorozu smiled politely at him, whereas Katsuki simply glared at the distance as if he wasn’t even there in the first place. Without further ado, the man turned around and left, heading back to the front where the sound equipment was at.

The weird, tense silence that ensued between himself and Yaoyorozu didn’t bother him in the slightest, since he didn’t have anything to say to her and he was pretty sure the opposite was also true. Rather than losing his time with a stupid attempt at small talk, which he hated doing, Katsuki went back to his article and tried to distract himself while the shitty speech didn’t start.

His focus didn’t last for too long, however. Because, less than ten minutes after Ears left, three dumbasses entered the auditorium, heading to the front row – as expected – and calling Katsuki’s attention.

Because there were three dumbasses when there should have been four.

The opening speech would begin in twenty minutes, but only Round Face, Icy Hot, and Class Rep made their way inside the auditorium. No Deku. Which was weird as fuck, all things considered.

He’s probably still waiting at the damn queue to take a picture with that shitty All Might statue, Katsuki’s brain supplied, but deep down he could tell something was off. He rarely had the patience to deal with Deku’s shitty friends, but he knew better than to assume they’d just leave Deku all alone on the damn All Might queue.

Round Face and Icy Hot were throwing themselves all over the nerd whenever the slightest opportunity appeared – Katsuki doubted they’d pass the chance to keep Deku company. Class Rep was too much of a responsible nerd to even consider the possibility of letting Deku out of his sight in a crowded public place while he was still recovering. So that probably meant *Deku* was the one who ditched them, and not the other way around. And yeah, he could have ditched them over something simple, like a quick trip to the bathroom. But he could also have ditched them over something stupid, like trying to sneak into the fucking All Might convention before it closed down. Hell if Katsuki knew.

Tch. This was none of his business, was it? Deku had made clear that Katsuki was no longer a part of his life; he had no reason to pry or to worry so much, then. Hadn't Deku insisted that he could take care of himself? That he was strong? That he didn't want to be treated like fucking porcelain or whatever? *Fine*. Katsuki wouldn't do that. He'd mind his own business and let Deku do his own thing.

Deku could take care of his damn self. Katsuki wouldn't pry anymore.

He scowled, unlocking his phone screen and going back to his article. It was about time he stopped wasting so much of his time on a person who clearly didn't give a shit about what he thought or did.

It was fruitless, though. The words of the article mended together and none of the phrases made sense anymore. It was like this was a whole different text from five minutes before, and when Katsuki found himself reading through the same paragraph for the third time over, he gave up and locked his phone again, putting it away with an angry scowl on his face.

Who the hell was he kidding? Deku might not want to be treated like porcelain, and he might be stronger than he was when Katsuki last spoke to him seven months before, but he sure as *hell* couldn't take care of himself.

He *never* could. His self-preservation instincts were equivalent to fucking *zero*. This was the guy who jumped at a villain even though he had no quirk just to save a brat who told him to kill himself; the guy who constantly broke his bones over and over again until the damage to his arms was irreversible; the guy who willingly became a fucking human shield for someone who only ever mistreated him.

The guy who went to a park full of flowers during spring, despite his allergies, just to celebrate Katsuki's birthday. The guy who learned sign language while being stuck to a hospital bed, just because Katsuki lost his hearing. The guy who tried to jump after him and save him when the League kidnapped him, even if both his arms had been broken and he had just been beaten into a pulp.

God. What an idiot. What a *fucking* idiot.

Katsuki sighed.

"Ears sure as fuck is taking her time grabbing that shitty wristband", he scoffed, turning to glare at Yaoyorozu.

She seemed to be a bit embarrassed by the fact that she was sitting in silence with Bakugou rather than being with her friends, but she nodded.

"I think so, too. I tried texting her, but my message didn't go through. I don't think I have phone reception in here, and there's no Wi-Fi, either", she commented.

Katsuki frowned, grabbing his own phone.

From: Bakugou

How the hell did you manage to get lost? I get the building has way more floors than necessary, but they're turning this opening speech into a big fucking deal

From: Bakugou

Just follow the damn signs that say "OPENING SPEECH – HERE", it's not that hard

Attention: The messages could not be delivered.

Huh. That was fucking weird.

From: Best Friend

Yo, Shitty Hair

Attention: The message could not be delivered.

Katsuki frowned.

"None of my messages are being sent", he told Yaoyorozu without really looking at her. He dialed Ears' number and pressed call.

"*We're sorry; you have reached a number that has been disconnected or is no longer in service. If you feel you have reached this recording in error, please check the number and try your call again*".

He dialed Kirishima's number and pressed call.

"*We're sorry; you have reached a number that has been disconnected or is no longer in service. If you feel you –*"

He ended the call.

"Are you fucking kidding me?", he huffed out, craning his head to look at the front row. Kirishima was sitting right there, chatting with Kaminari and Mina.

"Bakugou-kun –", Yaoyorozu started with reprimand in her tone, but Katsuki didn't hear her.

Someone jammed the signal. Someone jammed the signal so no one can talk to anyone outside, so they can trap us here and attack us and I need to be ready. I need to be ready if someone attacks us. I need to get Ears before this whole thing goes to shit. I need to find out if shitty Deku's just being stupid as usual or if he's in actual trouble. I can't just sit here when there could be villains around. Ears could be in danger. Deku could be in danger. They wouldn't have jammed the signal otherwise.

"I'll go find her", he announced shortly, standing up from his seat.

"Bakugou-kun", Yaoyorozu started again, tense, immediately reaching out for him and grabbing his arm to keep him in place. "The speech is about to start. I'm sure she'll be here in a moment".

"Then why can't we reach her? Why can't we reach anyone?", Katsuki asked matter-of-factly, frowning.

"Maybe there's no reception at the deposit –"

"I tried calling Kirishima and I got the same message. Even though the asshole is right over there", he pointed at him.

Yaoyorozu looked at the boy, and then back at Katsuki.

"It could be a safety measure", she explained patiently, looking like she was trying to calm down a feral beast. "To avoid live leaks. I've been to many important presentations; this is very common. The signal will be restored once it's over, Please, don't make a scene", she added, a bit too desperate.

Katsuki stared at her. She looked certain of what she was saying, and eager for him to sit back down. A few people were beginning to stare at his standing form, and while Yaoyorozu did look tense, she didn't look nervous at all – just urgent. As if *she* was the rational one and Katsuki was the fucking lunatic who went around throwing tantrums.

Compared to her, he must have seemed almost unhinged. He sat back down, even though he hated it.

"I'm sure she'll be right back", Yaoyorozu repeated, still sounding like she wanted him to calm down.

Well, that was condescending as fuck, in his opinion. His instinct was to tell her to shove it and just barge the fuck out of there out of spite, but a voice that sounded suspiciously like Doctor Matsuo's appeared at the back of his mind, reminding him of every possible tip to calm himself down and think rationally before he allowed his anger to get the best of him.

The mental exercise was hard, but it worked – and Katsuki found himself taking a deep breath and giving Yaoyorozu a half-hearted glare before nodding silently, deciding to trust the girl's judgement. She went to a lot fancier events than he did. Maybe she knew what she was talking about, and maybe Ears was just taking a while to adjust to the wristband, or maybe

she was actually lost, but already on her way. There were a lot of possibilities that explained her delay.

Maybe he'd been having a freak-out session over nothing, and it would be embarrassing as fuck to explain it later. If he had actually gone after Deku and found him, and if he was *okay,* what would Katsuki fucking tell him? *I was worried about you and wanted to make sure you were fine?* As if that had worked out well for him the last time he tried. Tch.

Yeah. Ok. Ears was on her way, Deku was just taking a shit, everything would be fine. No reason to freak out. No reason to imagine things. No reason to picture the worst-case scenario. Everything would turn out *fine*. He wasn't paranoid. He wasn't traumatized. He *wasn't.*

But… He couldn't help but to feel bothered by shitty Deku's absence. Not because he missed him or something – if anything, the past few months had taught Katsuki how to get used to his absence –, but because it was just… Unlike him.

He was supposed to be there already, bouncing on his front-row seat and eagerly waiting for his especial, exclusive All Might souvenir. He was supposed to be there, sitting and smiling and laughing with his shitty friends. He was supposed to *be there.*

Katsuki seriously considered howitzer-impacting his way down to rock bottom already and marching up to Deku's friends, meaning to ask them about the nerd's whereabouts. But, before he could even conceive how weird and humiliating that would be, something caught his attention, and he turned his head to see a worried frown on Yaoyorozu's face. She was leaning forward on her seat, trying to take a better look at the front of the auditorium.

"What?", he asked, urgency evident in his tone.

She spared Katsuki a quick glance before turning her attention back to the front of the auditorium, and Katsuki followed her gaze.

Tech guy was still checking the sound equipment, and now there was a new guy beside him – not the one who had walked Ears out, but a different one. He seemed pretty normal to Katsuki, but, from the way Yaoyorozu was reacting, something was off about him.

"That man, the new one", she provided, lowering her voice considerably even though there was no way the two men would have been able to hear her all the way back at the auditorium. "He was there at the park. On your birthday".

Katsuki might as well have been punched in the fucking stomach by Icy Hot's right side, because that was the only explanation for the cold feeling suddenly spreading in his guts.

He watched Yaoyorozu with attention.

"He was the one who had the sound quirk", Yaoyorozu continued, voice wavering from tension. "I was with Kyouka when it happened. His quirk was the one that messed with hers and made the…", she trailed off with a somber look.

She met Katsuki's eyes, wariness evident in them.

"I'm guessing it wouldn't be a stretch to say this ain't no coincidence", Katsuki responded, voice stern, all his senses being toned up by a hundred with focus and anticipation.

Yaoyorozu swallowed dry before she shook her head.

"It could be", she admitted with a half-hearted shrug before meeting his eyes again. "But I don't think it is".

Katsuki nodded simply.

He looked back at the front, trying to see if any of his shitty friends had noticed the same thing. They all seemed too distracted or caught up in conversation to pay the working men any attention, and Katsuki had no means to communicate with them because there was *no fucking reception*.

He grunted in annoyance. He'd have to figure out a way to talk to them and tell them there was something wrong without calling too much attention, without causing a –

Something caught his eyes.

Because of the shitshow that went down with his hearing, and because of the amount of time he spent going from one hearing aid to the next one while Pink Hair perfected it, Katsuki had gotten pretty good at lip reading. He wasn't exactly perfect at it (not that he would ever admit it), and he didn't even do it consciously at this point, really – it was just an ability he developed little by little and out of necessity over the course of the past months.

And, as it turns out, it was a pretty good ability to have – because, as his eyes found Deku's friends in an attempt to read their ugly faces for any signs of recognition, he found exactly what he was dreading the most.

Round Face was turned on her seat, her neck craned so she could stare at the auditorium's front door. On her face, a worried frown. She had her phone raised to her ear, and she put it down as fast as she had raised it up to her round face. Then, her mouth formed words that Katsuki couldn't hear, but that he could *read*.

I can't reach him. He should be here by now.

His legs moved before he could think.

Katsuki got to his feet, thankful that he had chosen a seat from which he could walk away easily.

"Bakugou-kun!", Yaoyorozu called after him, shocked, her voice barely above an urgent whisper.

"Stay here. I'll be right back, I'll go find them", he told her sternly.

Then, he paused.

“Don’t come after me”, he added pointedly. “You gotta be here in case Ears comes back”.

“Who’s *them*?”, she frowned, confused, but Katsuki was already gone.

Once he reached the front door of auditorium, a large, tall security guard stepped in front of him, blocking his way out.

His skin tingled. Ok, something was definitely wrong. This wasn’t paranoia. There were too many coincidences. Too much weird shit happening.

There was something *wrong.*

“Sorry, kid. No one goes out, only in. The speech is about to start”, he told Katsuki, who immediately scoffed in response.

“I need the bathroom”, Katsuki said simply, snappy.

The guard was unfaltering, not moving from where he was standing like a rock.

“Sorry. Boss’s orders”.

“Yeah?”, he clicked his tongue, raising his eyebrows. *Focus. Deep breaths*. “You tell your boss I’m gonna take a piss all over his fancy carpet in front of all of his shitty guests because *you* didn’t let me go to the *damn bathroom*. How about that?”

The security guard blinked at him, mouth agape, looking shocked.

“Y-You’re sure you’re training to be a hero, kid…?”

“Let me the hell through, you extra”, Katsuki scoffed again, walking past the security guard and bumping into him as he went. The man didn’t try to stop him this time, but Katsuki could feel his eyes glued on him as he walked away.

There were still a few people around the main hallway who hadn’t entered the auditorium yet, but it was *definitely* emptier than when Katsuki first arrived. But just as he had figured, Deku wasn’t anywhere around – and he wasn’t near the All Might expo, either, which only served to make the red alert blaring inside Katsuki’s skull more intense. He needed to check the bathroom.

Which was empty when he barged into it.

Fuck.

As he exited the empty bathroom he walked as fast as he could without turning his pace into a jog, trying not to attract suspicion to himself. He had no idea where the deposit was, but that was the only clue he had on that moment, since that was where Ears had allegedly headed to. He would need to work with that.

He supposed that a deposit for a museum building with 11 floors would be located at the lower levels. That way, the deposit would be hidden from the fancy guests and the location

would prevent random people from wandering in.

If that was the case, thinking logically, the damn deposit couldn't be too far from an elevator, otherwise equipment transport would take longer, be harder, and demand more people. Also, since the deposit probably stored flammable equipment, it also needed to be located near an emergency staircase, or at least near the security fire extinguishers.

Katsuki headed to the elevators, trying to spot either a fire extinguisher or an emergency exit on his way. By finding Ears first, wherever the girl was, he could make sure she was ok and also use her quirk to try and find Deku as well. It would be better than waste time and effort into looking for Deku first when he had no clues that led to the bastard.

He found that there were two small elevators at a smaller hall that intersected with the main one, but they both seemed to be directed towards guest use. No exits or fire extinguishers, either.

Tch. This was *not* what he had been expecting to find. These elevators were too small to lift cargo, and they were clearly meant to lift a limited amount of people, not heavy weight. He looked around with annoyance, asserting his surroundings and trying to figure out what to do next.

There was no one in sight, but he wouldn't count on things staying this calm for too long. The bathrooms were just as well signalized as the auditorium had been; if someone from security caught him here, he wouldn't be able to claim he had gotten lost looking for the bathroom without raising suspicion – which was the last thing he needed right now. Looking nervously above his shoulder and trusting his hearing aid would do its job and help him hear if someone approached him, Katsuki kept walking past the elevators. Maybe he could find something –

He overheard a faint pair of footsteps coming from the direction he was headed to, and, knowing his hearing, the people were probably closer than they sounded. Katsuki walked back the way he came and turned on a corner, this time heading straight ahead on the main hall. Miraculously, he found a door just a few meters ahead, and without sparing a look at it he opened it, stepping in, and closing it silently behind him.

He stayed there, head glued to the door, waiting until the footsteps and the light conversation disappeared in the distance. Then, once the sounds were gone, he waited for even longer, just to be sure the two people were actually gone and this was not a simple misconception of his impaired hearing.

By the time he was sure he was clear, he let out a shaky breath and allowed himself to gather his surroundings. The place was dark, but there was a faint neon light shining on the wall, next to a sign.

Emergency stairs.

Well. Jackpot…?

He slowly opened the door of the internal emergency stairs as silently as he could. He peeked around before he stepped out, and, once he did, he made sure to close the door behind him silently again. The hallway was back to empty, so he walked back to the hall with the elevators and continued to head past them. Then, he turned on a corner to his left, where there was another hall with a smaller auditorium.

This second hall was parallel to the hall where the main auditorium was located, which meant there was *probably* a backdoor to it somewhere to Katsuki's right. Because the tech team didn't usually load the equipment for presentations through the front door of the auditorium – they loaded it through the backdoor. If there were two entryways for the auditorium and the front entry was in the main hall, there was a high chance the secondary hall –

Bingo. There, between the backdoor of the main auditorium and the front door of the smaller auditorium, was a freight elevator. It was close enough to the emergency stairs, it was positioned next to two auditoriums as a way to maximize efficiency, and there was even a fire extinguisher at the end of the hall, as Katsuki had predicted.

He couldn't help but to grin victoriously as he marched towards the elevator's doors.

They were closed and the elevator seemed to be stationed at another floor, which meant Katsuki would have to press the button in order to bring it up. He didn't want to risk bringing the elevator up with someone – some *villain* – inside it, and in case he used it to go down to the deposit he could be easily cornered, since that was a metal box with only one way out. Therefore, he went back the way he came yet again and headed back towards the emergency stairs.

Now that he knew what direction to follow in order to find the freight elevator, which he was fairly sure would be close to the deposit, he could simply climb his way down using the internal emergency stairs. They were a much safer route than using the elevator, since it was unlikely the villains would use it to go up and down eleven stairs, and, in case they *did* use it, Katsuki would have a lot more space and mobility for a combat than he would have inside the elevator.

Now, all he needed to do was figure out what floor he was supposed to head for.

The opening speech was being held on the top floor of the building – the only thing above it was the roof. Katsuki assumed the deposit would be located on the lower floor, possibly an underground floor – to prevent the crew from disrupting the events of the expo *and* to prevent the guests from wandering in by accident.

He could be wrong, but he wanted to check the underground first, since it was the most logical place for the deposit to be located at. If it wasn't there, all he would have to do was climb back up and check floor by floor.

As he climbed down the stairs as silently as he could, he tried calling Ears again, but it was no use – all he got was the same "no signal" message. From the time on his clock, the opening speech had already begun, but there were no missed calls or texts on his phone telling him to hurry up or asking him where he was.

Ergo: his friends still had no reception up there.

Sighing, Katsuki put his phone away.

He knew the top floor and the floors directly beneath it were reserved for the museum's many expositions and events. He *didn't* know if there was more than one underground floor, but if there were, he would check them one by one as well. There was something wrong about Ears and Deku not showing up on time, and he could feel it. He wouldn't just do nothing and let something like that slide.

As it turned out, Katsuki didn't have to check too many underground floors – actually, there was only one. But as soon as he stepped out of the emergency stairs on level -1 and headed to the freight elevator, he spotted what he had been looking for: a large door labeled "deposit" down the hallway.

He did feel a bit smug for figuring it out so easily, and he did allow a smirk to blossom on his lips, but the feeling of victory didn't last for too long.

Focus.

Ok. The hallway was empty. There were no people around. In fact, no one seemed to be at that floor at all, which was a bit suspicious, to say the least. Nevertheless, he carefully walked towards the deposit, looking over his shoulder to make sure he wasn't being followed or seen.

As he reached the closed door, he gently pressed his good ear against it, trying to catch any signs of life or movement coming from inside. He couldn't hear anything that caught his attention.

Katsuki twisted the knob and opened the door, quickly stepping inside and closing it behind him as quietly as he could to prevent being spotted from the hallway should anyone arrive. And as soon as he spun on his heels in order to take a look at his surroundings and assess the inside of the deposit, a movement from the corner of his eye caught his attention.

His body reacted out of instinct and years of training, and he had already moved out of the way before his brain could catch up with the fact that *someone had just attacked him with a crowbar*.

After he dodged the erratic blow, he spun on his heels, quickly grabbing the lowered crowbar with one hand and using his free one to grab his attacker by the front of his shirt. Katsuki yanked the crowbar from the attacker's hand with one swift move and used the hand that was grasping the guy's shirt to pull him and throw him on the ground.

The guy's back collided with the floor harshly, and as soon as he was down, Katsuki climbed on the top of him to pin him down, exactly like he used to do in his training sessions with Deku. Katsuki raised the crowbar he had yanked from the attacker up, ready to strike him down.

He panted, finally allowing his frantic, high-on-adrenaline, full-in-attack-mode brain to take in the sight in front of his eyes. To take in the sight of his *attacker*.

And then the crowbar fell from his raised hand, a mixture of fury, concern, and the utmost *rage* erupting on his face.

“You goddamn *idiot*”, he barked out, way more loudly than he had intended. “I could have *blown your fucking face off*!”

Because there, lying on the floor beneath him, stuck between his thighs, was Deku, staring up at him with wide eyes and a bleeding gash on his forehead.

And a few meters away from them, lying unconscious on the floor of the deposit, with her hands tied behind her back and a duct tape covering her mouth, was Jirou, yet to be noticed by Katsuki’s shocked self.

Chapter End Notes

Well... The next one should be up soon. It's almost ready, actually. It's the third part that still needs some working.

Also, forget everything I've ever said about a chapter count and don't ever believe me if I talk about that again. I have no idea how long this will turn out. Still hope it's good, though.

Bakugou, my boy... You're so oblivious. God, it hurts to write. Can't they just figure their shit out already??? Bastards.

(It's entirely my fault)

For those who don't follow me on twitter: I was writing the new chapter and it was turning out idk, over 60K words long. So I decided to split it into three different chapters, because I wanted to update already and the first part was good to go. The second part is ready too, I just need to revise it before I post it. The third part... Well. That's the part everyone's waiting for. But we'll get there. Don't worry.

Kudos and comments are appreciated as usual, and thanks so much to everyone who leaves encouragements and praises and nice words for me! My heart beats faster every time I get the e-mail notificating me of a new comment. It really makes my whole day to read what you guys thought, you have no idea. When I'm writing I keep thinking "I wonder if someone will make a comment on that"... and you guys always do. It's amazing, really. You guys are the sugoi ones. Also, I'm pretty sure people in the subway must be tired of seeing me smile and squeal whenever I read a new comment when I'm on my way to work. So thanks, from the bottom of my angsty heart.

Anyway... See you guys next time :-)

Chapter 23: Win To Save

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

After his fight with Deku, sometimes Katsuki's mind would pop with a question about what would be the first thing he'd say to the nerd if they ever went back to talking.

He wasn't a daydreaming idiot, at least not to the point of believing he and Deku would ever be *friends* again. But he still had One For All, and he *would* have to give it back to the nerd at some point. A point which was apparently becoming closer, since Deku seemed to be getting stronger every day. And it wasn't like Katsuki could simply walk up to him after months of silence, yank out a chunk of his hair, shove it in the nerd's mouth, force him to swallow it, and be done with that shitty story that was almost hitting the one-year mark.

Well – he wished he could do that. It would make his life a whole lot easier, that was for fucking certain. But he was fairly sure that, even if he did pass One For All back to Deku like *that,* All Might would still need to talk to the both of them about what had happened, which meant that he would still have to face Deku in a way. And Katsuki couldn't say he felt exactly excited about the idea of being stuck in a room with Deku after hypothetically forcing him to swallow his hair without a word, following months of ignoring each other because Katsuki was a dick. *Especially* because that Deku would remember everything from the ghost times – the cuddling, and the arguments, and the separation… and every single thing Katsuki did while he was amnesiac. How much of an asshole he was. How inconsiderate he was.

Not that Katsuki cared about all that, at *all*. Not that he cared what shitty Deku would think of him, or that talking to shitty Deku was something of relevance, or that the way he would pass One For All back to the nerd mattered, or that the first words he said to him after their months-long fight would make any difference. He didn't give a shit, honestly. He really didn't. But…

But the problem was, they had gone through too much. The soulbond, and the dying, and the quirk, and the memory loss, and the recovery, and the fight… Whereas Katsuki was done pretending he didn't care about Deku, he was also done having such a complicated relationship with him.

They clearly didn't belong together, if the amount of fighting and hurting and arguing was anything to go by. So yeah, shoving the damn hair into the damn nerd's mouth without a word and walking away would be the most appropriate way to end the shitshow that their dynamics had become.

But Katsuki knew it wouldn't give him the closure he so obviously needed.

Because, as much as he despised the thought, he wished his story with Deku could come to a proper end, if an end was so inevitable. It was only appropriate, after the bond they had created – after the bond that had been forced upon them. A definitive end, one that wouldn't leave any room for loose ends or awkward glances in the hallways of UA. One that would

halt that hollow feeling inside of Katsuki's chest whenever he watched Deku laughing happily with his friends from afar – whenever he woke up in the middle of the night with the image of Deku's dead eyes etched in his brain. An end that would finally label them as what they now were: *former* childhood friends, *former* soulmates.

Current acquaintances.

(But still rivals. Because, as much as Katsuki felt differently for Deku now, and as much as he *saw* him differently, his desire to be the number one hero who surpassed All Might remained unfaltering. Which obviously only made everything he was feeling even more complicated.)

One For All was apparently the only connection they still had left – the only reason they would still *need* to talk to each other, at some point. And Katsuki wasn't selfish enough to wish he could keep the nerd's quirk for a little longer, if only it would mean his bond with Deku wouldn't be broken beyond repair once he had One For All back – in reality, Katsuki couldn't *wait* to get rid of the damn thing.

He hated having Deku's quirk. He hated that he had been the one to make Deku quirkless again, that he had been the one to make him so powerless. He hated the knowledge that Deku would continue to throw himself into danger like the self-sacrificing idiot he had always been, and he hated that *he*, Katsuki, had been the one to take away Deku's only means of defense, after mocking him for being defenseless for so long.

He hated that he was bearing One For All, even though he hadn't been All Might's chosen one. He hated that he could feel the power coursing through his veins, even though he had only been a second option, a replacement, a scapegoat. And he hated that, for him to give Deku his quirk back, they would be forced into talking, at least one last time. Even if Deku didn't want to. Even if Deku had made it *very clear* that he didn't want to.

He hated that he had come to care so much about Deku. About what he did, and said, and thought, and wanted. It still made him feel sick, sometimes. And yet…

He was in too deep, now. He couldn't bring himself to *stop* caring, not after everything. Not after…

Tch.

So Katsuki had spent a while, in spite of himself, thinking about what he'd say to Deku when the occasion came. In case he *absolutely* had to say something, of course, instead of just shoving his quirk back at him and being done with it, memories or no memories. And while he had a lot of ideas, he ended up discarding all of them: none conveyed what he wished to say with the precision he wanted.

Which sucked. And made him angry.

Therefore, because he was a person who knew how to control his feelings now, Katsuki decided to only cross that bridge when he absolutely came to it and to *stop worrying* about

that shitty talk so long before it even happened – especially since he didn't even know *if* it would happen.

He still caught himself thinking about that subject sometimes, though, but mostly, he decided he was better off ignoring it, for the sake of his own emotional estate. He already had enough shit on his plate as it was, he didn't need to stress out over this crap as well. He'd figure out what to say when it was time to speak to Deku again, and that was it.

The words would come naturally to him; he was sure of it. He would know *exactly* what to say when the time came. No need to worry. No need to overthink something as stupid as this when he had better shit to do.

Of course, he couldn't exactly have foreseen that his first words to Deku, after half a year of silence and so much drama and worrying, would be: "*You goddamn idiot, I could have blown your fucking face off!*". But, if Katsuki had to be fair, those were probably appropriate first words for such a shitty relationship.

From what it seemed, Deku *also* hadn't expected those words, because he was staring at Katsuki with wide, surprised eyes from where he was stuck between his legs.

Once it finally dawned on him that he was pinning Deku between his thighs on the floor of a deposit room and that he had been a split second away from bashing his skull in with the very crowbar he had snatched from the nerd, Katsuki removed himself from the top of Deku.

With a disbelieving huff, he got back to his feet and grabbed the nerd's arm, hoisting him up so that he was standing up as well without offering him any sort of warning. By doing so, he couldn't help but to notice that Deku was heavier than he had been the last time they sparred – and he was a bit buffer, too. Definitely not as light as he used to be all those months ago, when Katsuki used to pull him to his feet in that exact same way after knocking him down and pinning him to the floor during their training sessions.

"K-Kacchan!", Deku exclaimed, clearly taken aback but managing to keep his voice barely above a whisper. "What are you doing here?"

"What are *you* doing here?", Katsuki retorted in an equally whispered-yet-urgent tone. "And why the fuck is your head *bleeding*?", he squinted at the gash on Deku's forehead, which was still oozing blood sluggishly.

Katsuki knew he hadn't been the one to cause that injury – all he did was yank the damn crowbar off Deku's hand and throw him on the ground; quick, clean and effective. His maneuver had been intended to immobilize his opponent, not injure him – and the blood, along with the fact that Deku was down there at the deposit room, indicated he had gotten himself into trouble on his own. *Again.*

"I – What?", Izuku took a hand to his forehead, frowning, and seeming even more surprised when his fingers came back stained red. So, apparently, he didn't even fucking remember having been hit on the head. Great. How fucking reassuring.

“For fuck’s sake”, Katsuki sighed and growled under his breath, leaning in closer to the idiot to check his wound.

The deposit room was dark. Currently, the only source of light came from a small lightbulb hanging above them, which enveloped their immediate surroundings in a dim yellow light. There seemed to be larger lamps on the tall ceiling, but they were turned off and Katsuki couldn’t risk calling unwanted attention from someone outside if he turned them on.

The poor lighting made the blood covering half of Deku’s face look creepier than it already was, and Katsuki squinted as he tried his best to assess the gravity of the damage. Eventually, he settled for grabbing his useless phone and turning the flashlight on, aiming it at Deku’s forehead.

Deku hissed at the sudden light filling his eyes. The blood flow from the cut was slow and the gash didn’t seem too deep, but it was hard to tell for sure – head injuries always were tricky. Even if the cut was superficial, they would still need to cover it in order to stanch the bleeding, and then Deku would probably be ok until they found help.

At least, that was what Katsuki wanted to believe. He wouldn’t doubt Deku’s ability to turn an apparently simple head injury into something life-threatening that sent him to death’s door yet again.

And then his eyes would be empty and staring at nothing and he would be –

Ok. *Focus*.

“I – I was just looking f-for… Uh, Jirou-san –“, Deku stuttered, clearly nervous by the newfound fact that there was a bleeding wound on his forehead *and* by Katsuki’s sudden proximity. He was still squinting as he nervously craned his neck to look somewhere behind them, further into the deposit room, and, as Katsuki followed Deku’s line of sight, he spotted a limp body lying on the floor a few feet away.

Holy fucking shit. Ears.

The girl was lying unconscious on her side, her arms tied behind her back, her ankles tied together, and her mouth covered by a grey duct tape. As an instinct, Katsuki immediately rushed to her side, Deku close behind him.

And then a sudden realization hit him, and he stopped on his tracks before he could get to Jirou.

Who was tied up. And gagged. *And* unconscious. And the only other person in that room was…

Fuck.

Fuck. It couldn’t be. Could it be?

… Could it be? Couldn’t it be? He *had* been holding a crowbar. And – And why was he down here in the first fucking place? If he was looking for Jirou, how did he know where to look?

How did he get to the deposit? It wasn't an instinctive conclusion.

Was that even *Deku*? That girl from the League could turn into other people, Katsuki knew that. And that other crazy bastard could make copies that were exactly like people. There were probably similar quirks around, whether this was the League or not. From everything that was happening, from all his "paranoid" suspicions being confirmed in a row, Katsuki was in no position to let something as fishy as that go overlooked, right?

Right. *Right. Focus.*

Deku, not having foreseen Katsuki's abrupt stop, bumped into his back in his rush to follow him. Before he could either fall to the floor from the sudden impact or manage to regain his balance on his own, Katsuki turned on his heels at the speed of light and grabbed Deku's arms, squeezing hard to prevent him from freeing himself.

Deku hissed in discomfort and surprise, looking confused by the turn of events, but he downright yelped when Katsuki spun him around, pushed him several feet back, which made him stumble, and slammed him against the harsh surface of a shelf that was standing right behind Jirou's limp body.

The contents of the shelf rattled loudly from the impact and Deku flinched, trying to break free from Katsuki's hold.

"Ouch, Kacchan –!"

"Shut up", Katsuki cut him off with a growl, his tone authoritative, looking deep inside Deku's eyes as he studied it, searching for something.

He let go of Deku's arms but held him in place by pressing one of his forearms against the nerd's neck, pinning his head to the shelf. Katsuki used his free hand to direct the flashlight of his phone over Deku's face, still searching it for something, but also making the boy squint even more at the bright light.

Izuku tried to turn his head away to preserve his sensitive eyes, both of his hands shooting up to grab at Katsuki's forearm that was nearly choking him.

"Ka…cchan…", Deku tried, wheezing and squeezing his eyes shut, but Katsuki only pressed harder against him with a vengeance. He could feel the way Deku's Adam's apple bobbed up and down against his arm as he tried to swallow.

"I said *shut up*", he commanded, nostrils flaring and heart racing inside his chest. He needed to be sure. *He needed to be sure.* "Look at me", he added, his tone leaving no space for refusal.

Deku's lips snapped shut into a grimace and he swallowed dry again, fingers still clutching to Katsuki's arm in a feeble attempt to set himself free. He managed to open one of his eyes just a bit, flinching at the bright light that immediately met it and squeezing it shut again.

Katsuki scowled. He needed to see Deku's *eyes.*

“K-Kacchan”, he choked out, “W-What are you –“

“Open your *eyes*, Deku”, Katsuki ordered again, shifting his hold on the phone so that the flashlight would illuminate Deku’s face, but not shine directly upon his eyes.

Izuku did as he was told – still squinting, but less than before. He blinked nervously at Katsuki, still struggling to breathe properly.

Katsuki leaned in, staring deeply into Deku’s face. Deku looked worried and confused, incapable of opening his eyes more than a slit due to the beaming flashlight shining on his face. Katsuki looked as fierce and determined as ever, not allowing his emotions to show on his face.

They stared at each other.

“Tell me something only Deku would know”, he commanded, impassive, ignoring the amount of blood that was covering half of Deku’s face and hiding his freckles away from view. His eyes seemed fine, but Katsuki needed to be sure.

The frowning on Deku’s squinting face relaxed a bit. His shoulders slumped and he swallowed dry again, struggling to make eye-contact with Katsuki but trying his best to maintain it despite the sharp spikes of pain the light was sending across his skull.

“Kacchan”, he said calmly, looking like he had finally figured out the solution to a difficult problem. He also sounded like he was trying to calm a feral beast down, which only made Katsuki feel even more pissed off. “She was a-already like that when I woke up. You don’t have to worry, it’s really me –“

“Then *prove it*”, Katsuki barked, pressing harder against Deku in his urgency.

“Ghh –“, Deku emitted a choking sound at the new pressure, his mouth opening wide as he tried to suck in a breath. His grip on Katsuki’s arm grew tighter, almost pleading, which made the explosive boy loosen his hold just a tiny bit – just so Deku could answer his question. The boy gasped and coughed shortly, trying to catch his breath.

For a while, Deku only breathed and gasped and clung to Katsuki’s arm with his fingertips. There was still discomfort on his face, but he looked a bit calmer, now that he knew what had caused Katsuki’s reaction – the fear that he could be a villain in disguise, or a double. Izuku couldn’t really judge him for thinking that – with everything they had gone through so far, the possibility wasn’t off the table, and it couldn’t be easily dismissed, either, especially in those circumstances. He took in a deep breath and sighed, his grip still tight on Katsuki’s forearm, before pointing him with a cautious look.

“W-When I was five”, Deku said with a hoarse voice. “On my birthday. I cried because I didn’t want to cut the cake. It was an A-All Might cake, and I didn’t want to ruin it by cutting his face. So you took the knife and you cut it for me”.

Katsuki stared at him. His hold on Deku loosened further, but he still didn’t let go completely.

“A-And you also called me wimpy for not wanting to cut it”, Deku added with a sound that could have been a nervous laughter or an exasperated huff. His voice lacked humor.

Silence.

They merely stared at each other, Deku still squinting in discomfort at the harsh light directed at his face and grunting a bit as he tried to shift his weight from one foot to another without success.

“*What*?”, Deku asked after a few moments, impatient. Didn’t that prove it?

“What else?”, Katsuki scoffed, unrelenting.

“Kacchan, *how* would I know that unless –“

“I’m not fucking playing games with you”, he cut Deku off, pressing against him once more but just enough to keep him in place. “Just answer the damn question”.

Izuku sighed, averting his eyes upwards before meeting Katsuki’s intense gaze again.

“Fine”, he complied, looking slightly angry and very determined. “I taught you the All Might dance when we were kids and we used to do it together all the time until you decided it was baby stuff. We liked playing Hero Agency in the park and you’d always make me be the sidekick instead of the main hero. We used to have that cheap All Might sticker album and I’d go over to your place so we could exchange the ones we already had, and sometimes you’d let me take two stickers instead of one because you knew how much I loved the chroma ones”.

Katsuki glared at him.

Izuku glared back. When Katsuki didn’t say anything, he sighed and continued.

“Your mom liked me, I think. She used to call me ‘Bunny Boy’ because I was always hopping around whenever All Might appeared on TV while I was over. I only slept over at your place once, when we were around 5, before you got your quirk. There was this one time when my mom and your mom decided to do a one-day trip together and they brought us along to the beach and it was the most fun I’ve ever had at that time. Is that enough for you, or do you want me to keep going?”

Katsuki scoffed.

“Don’t act so damn *smart*, idiot”.

Izuku scoffed back.

“It really *is* me, Kacchan”, he retorted, mildly annoyed.

Katsuki loosened his grip further, but didn’t let go completely. He was no longer pinning Deku against the shelf, but his arm remained there beside his head, like a warning that he wasn’t out of the woods yet.

“What about your quirk?”, Katsuki asked. That was the one subject that would definitely prove if this was really Deku or just some double with stolen memories.

Izuku looked sad and annoyed at the same time. then, out of a sudden – suspicious.

“How do I know *you’re* Kacchan?”, he frowned, tensing up. “How do I know you’re not just trying to make me talk –“

“Deku”, Katsuki growled, leaning in closer to him. “Answer the fucking question”.

“No, *you* answer my question”, Deku retorted, determined, suspicious, and still tense beneath Katsuki. “How do I know you’re really Kacchan?”

Katsuki narrowed his eyes.

“The reason you still call me *Kacchan* is because you were too dumb to learn how to say my name properly”, he said hoarsely, with no hesitation. Izuku was glad the room was dark, lest Kacchan see the blush that tinged his cheeks. “And you mumble in your sleep. *And* you like your mom’s katsudon better than mine, which I find fucking offensive”.

Fine, that was… That was fair. There was no way someone pretending to be Kacchan would know all that, right? Especially the – the sleeping part. And the – well…

But Kacchan still didn’t believe him. Izuku would have to say something really personal if he wanted to convince the clearly suspicious boy.

“You stopped talking to me after you found out I was quirkless”, he said, hesitant. “And you started pretending we had never been friends”.

Silence. Suddenly, Katsuki knew where this was going.

Izuku hated going back to that subject, but he just wanted Kacchan to trust him.

“And in our last year in school, you… You told me to kill myself if I wanted a quirk so badly”.

Katsuki’s nose twitched.

A pregnant pause.

They simply stared at each other, the tension between them reaching astronomical levels.

“*Fine*”, Katsuki settled for saying, letting go of the stupid shelf more abruptly than he had to. Its contents rattled softly again, filling the room with a metallic sound for a few seconds.

“Do you believe me now?”, Izuku asked, hesitant.

“What do you think?”, Katsuki scoffed.

Izuku sighed.

“Great”, he said, relaxing and leaning his head back. He looked serious. “Can you please turn off that light, now? It’s making my headache worse”.

“Tch”.

Katsuki lowered the phone and turned his back to Deku, walking back towards Jirou. There was nothing else he could possibly say after this weird shitshow.

He knelt beside his friend as if he and the nerd hadn’t just shared what must have been the world’s weirdest interaction ever. Deku followed him silently and, once they were close enough to each other, Katsuki raised his hand to offer Deku his phone, not meeting his eyes and focusing them on Jirou instead.

“Hold that”, he instructed simply.

Deku silently grabbed the phone and directed the flashlight towards Jirou from where he was standing beside Katsuki’s kneeling form.

Katsuki started the process of unfastening the ropes that were tying her wrists. Deku continued to provide him with light and silence.

This went on for a while.

“So you’re gonna fucking tell me what happened or what?”, Katsuki snapped after a few moments of awkward silence, just as he resumed untying Jirou’s hands and moved on to her ankles. “What the hell are you doing down here?”

Izuku hesitated.

“I – I was trying to free Jirou-san when I heard you on the hall”, Deku said with a wobbly voice. “I thought you could be a v-villain, so I left her as she was and grabbed the crowbar to defend us”.

“That’s not what I fucking asked”, Katsuki complained as he continued to unfasten Jirou’s bindings. At least that explained why the asshole had jumped at him with a crowbar when he arrived, but it also sent a dull wave of irritation across Katsuki’s chest.

Because even if Deku had tried to fend for himself despite his current lack of a quirk, which was good, he had still fucking *missed*, which was terrible.

And Katsuki had been standing *right in front* of him. What if he had actually been a villain? Deku would be fucking dead by now, that’s where he’d be. The idiot was clearly helpless, which was why he shouldn’t be *fucking* wandering around and getting himself in trouble, ready to dive in headfirst into danger and play the little fucking martyr as he always did –

Ok. *Ok.* Focus.

He couldn’t let his anger, his thoughts, or his angry thoughts get the best of him. He had a situation in his hands. He could worry about shitty Deku’s shitty defense methods and give him a proper scolding later, when they weren’t under imminent threat.

“I – I just woke up a few minutes ago, I think”, Deku tried again, swallowing dry. “Uh – everything was fuzzy, but when I woke up, I was tied up, like Jirou-san. Except I think they must have underestimated me, or maybe they, uh, overestimated themselves… because I think I woke up before they expected me to...? The ropes weren’t really tied well, it was clearly a rushed job, and all I could think about was Midnight sensei’s class on rope tying and different types of knots, remember that? I think it was, like, two months ago, maybe, I don’t really remember right now, and I – well. I managed to, uh… free myself pretty fast”.

Katsuki wanted to scream at Deku for digressing so much, but he had bigger problems at hands. The fact that Jirou (and apparently Deku) had been properly restrained – their captors had used ropes and duct tape – indicated whatever plan these villains had going on wasn’t something erratic or made up in the last minute. It had been planned out – from getting Jirou out of the auditorium to locking her down here.

Hell, for all Katsuki knew, this whole shitty villain attack could have been planned out from the very day they celebrated his birthday at the park, since the guy with the sound quirk had been there, too. That couldn’t have been a coincidence.

Maybe they had been testing out how to make Jirou’s quirk react like it did – making that explosive noise. Maybe they had been watching them, studying them. He didn’t know for sure. The only thing he *did* know was that whatever the fuck was going on had been thought-through enough for the villains to bring in what they needed to restrain people – which proved they had expected to be met with resistance.

“And why the fuck were you captured and tied up in the first place?”, Katsuki scoffed. “Shine it over here”, he added, nodding at Jirou’s head.

Deku did as he was told, shifting positions so that he could illuminate Jirou’s head properly. From what Katsuki could see, there weren’t any cuts, lumps, bruises, or blood on the girl. No gashes on her forehead or signs of physical violence at all – which meant she and Deku had probably been captured by different villains, since the asshat had clearly been knocked out by a blow to the head whereas Ears seemed to have been urged into unconsciousness somehow. Maybe by a drug? He couldn’t really be sure.

Ok. If there had been any doubt before, now he could be sure this wasn’t a one-man’s work. This wasn’t just the Sound Quirk guy or just the douche who led Jirou away. There were more villains involved – and now that he thought about it, there *had* to be, right? Katsuki didn’t know what was going down on the auditorium upstairs, but he didn’t have to guess it was probably something bad, if the villains felt the need to *kidnap* a fucking schoolgirl and lock the doors so that no one could get out. And taking down an auditorium that size demanded *muscle*.

Katsuki turned to look at Deku again, finding him still standing idly by his side with a concerned look in his glassy eyes. *The asshat is probably concussed and doesn’t even know it*, Katsuki’s brain supplied after a quick glance. Sensibility to light, blown out pupils, confusion… Upon his sudden glare, Deku was reminded he was taking too long to answer Katsuki’s question and swallowed dry.

“I – I saw Jirou-san being led away by a large guy when I was coming back from the bathroom”, he provided. “I was headed to the auditorium, and… Well. They seemed fine, she didn’t seem – scared, or anything, but I caught a glimpse of her when she entered the elevator with him. I saw her topple to the side as if she had fainted, and I saw him grab her, but the elevator door closed before I could do anything. It – it didn’t look like she was sick or anything a moment before, so I found it... Weird. I figured something was wrong, and even if it wasn’t, it’d be better to check, just to make sure. So I followed her down through the emergency stairs”.

How fucking great. So Deku had the same idea as he did, and he only got into this mess as a result of sheer dumb luck – as it always seemed to be the case. Being at the wrong place in the wrong time and somehow still profiting from it was apparently Deku’s hidden quirk.

Not that getting bashed in the head could be considered “profiting” per say, but Katsuki *did* find both idiots at the same place instead of having to look for each of them individually, after all. And while he wished he could say he was glad to have killed two birds with one stone, the amount of blood on Deku’s face and the sheer unresponsiveness of Ears beside him obliterated any possible sense of relief he could have felt on that moment.

“And then *what*? You’re just throwing facts at me”, Katsuki urged impatiently, shifting so that he could get to his feet once Ears’ arms and legs were free from the ropes. He left the now unrestrained but still unconscious Jirou where she was on the floor and wandered off, starting to assess the shelves right behind her and trusting Deku to follow him close. He started off with the shelf he had pushed Deku against, looking for something while he waited for his response.

The deposit room was large and wide in comparison to the hall that led to it, and its ceiling stretched up tall, sustained by thick columns. The majority of the room was occupied by equally tall metal shelves, which were large and strong enough to stock the equipment an 11-story museum building would require to function.

Deku followed Katsuki close-by as he assessed the stuff stocked in the front shelves of the room. The nerd stuttered and muttered to himself as he tried to come up with a coherent timeline of events – everything he had said so far was scrambled and out of chronological order. The hesitant sounds he was making reminded Katsuki of that period of time right after the coma, when Deku couldn’t speak or form sentences properly.

A wave of nostalgia hit him at full strength, mixing with his already raising anxiety and his adrenaline.

He hated it.

“It – It wasn’t easy, following them”, Deku continued, swallowing dry. “I had no idea where he could be taking her, so I had to check floor by floor. Which was stupid now that I think about it, b-because all I had to do was wait until the elevator stopped and see the f-floor they had dropped off at on the display, but I – I was really worried and I didn’t think, my legs moved before I could really make a plan, so I just – Well. A-And I wasn’t caught until I reached the first floor. I tried to make it look like I’d gotten lost looking for the All Might expo, since…”

He gestured at the All Might shirt he was wearing – the shirt Katsuki had left out for him on his birthday, and that apparently was *no big fucking deal* to Deku since he was talking about it so casually.

(A bit of blood had spilled on its front, from the gash on Deku's forehead. The realization that the shirt was probably ruined made Katsuki's chest feel tight, but he ignored it. He didn't even know why it had felt like that in the first place.)

"But the guy didn't buy it", Izuku continued with a shrug, unaware of Katsuki's reaction. "He said he would escort me back to the auditorium because I shouldn't be there, and at least that's what I thought he was doing, but before I could say anything or even explain to him about Jirou-san, something hit my head and everything went black. And I woke up here".

"With your head punched in", Katsuki said casually, not looking at Deku while he continued to search the shelves for something.

"Yeah", Deku said, deflated.

Katsuki rolled his eyes, finally finding what he had been looking for at a shelf a bit far to the right: a roll of duct tape. Beside it, there were several meters of rope – the same type Jirou had been tied with –, along with a pair of scissors, a bunch of chemical bottles and other mechanical tools similar to Deku's crowbar.

Katsuki scoffed in disdain at these criminals. To leave the very means they had used to restrain their victims so accessible, right there, in order to spare them the trouble of looking for it … It was despicable. It was like mocking those they had captured and everyone who was attending the shitty event upstairs and was a potential victim. And they hadn't even bothered to tie Deku up properly!

Katsuki was suddenly filled with an indescribable sense of anger. What a bunch of amateur D-listers. Couldn't even commit their crimes properly. And Deku and Ears had been so easily *captured* by those guys, who were clearly so incompetent. How pathetic.

Tch.

He grabbed the duct tape, turning on his heels to face Deku.

"I – I was checking on Jirou-san when I heard you coming in", Deku repeated himself, that glassy look still lingering in his eyes. He looked like he was searching for something – anything – to say and fill the silence, or to at least make Katsuki believe his story.

"You said that already", Katsuki responded shortly, suppressing the frown that was threatening to appear on his face.

"Oh", Izuku blinked and frowned, seeming surprised.

Katsuki squinted at him. Maybe he shouldn't have been so aggressive to Deku before. Maybe he should be worrying more about his concussion.

Sigh.

“Keep going”, Katsuki instructed simply, meaning to force Deku into talking. This way, he could keep a close eye on the bastard and make sure he was awake *and* at least a bit coherent. He pulled out a large piece of duct tape and cut it off the roll using his bare teeth as he waited for Deku to continue.

“I saw her as soon as I got rid of my ropes, and t-then I realized there was something wrong, because she wasn’t waking up”, Izuku shrugged. “And then I heard you on the hall. B-But I didn’t know you were you, I thought you were a villain coming to finish the job, and there was this crowbar sitting by at that corner over there, I have no idea why they’d leave something like that so close to the people they kidnapped, but I grabbed it and I was ready to strike you, but – uh…”

A pause. Katsuki watched him closely.

“I… I recognized you. Right in the last second”, Izuku admitted. “S-So I pulled back before I could hit you in the head, and then *you* were grabbing *me* and I was on the floor”.

Katsuki continued to stare at him for a split second, his eyes narrowing.

Then, he scoffed. Was Deku *seriously* going to try and act like *he* was the one who had just saved Katsuki, and not the other way around? What a fucking martyrdom complex.

“Sure. You missed the blow *on purpose*”, he commented sarcastically, placing the roll of tape beneath one of his armpits so that both his hands would be free.

Izuku glared at him in the dark, slightly offended.

“Yes. Do you have a problem with that?”, he retorted with defiance, sounding way more confident than he had just a split moment ago. Forcefully so, even, despite his concussion.

Katsuki glared at him again, not liking the offended hint in Deku’s voice. The asshole was *really* digging for a fight, wasn’t he? Now that he had finally decided to stand up for himself, he couldn’t seem to stop, even when he was deadass *wrong.* And it pissed Katsuki off beyond belief, but they didn’t have the time to go toe to toe with each other on that moment. He needed to *focus*.

He didn’t offer Deku a snappy response like he wanted to (*Yeah, I have a problem with that, because I was clearly the one who dodged the blow, and if I had been a villain you’d be toast by now, you brainless fuck, are you even physically capable of taking care of yourself properly??*). Instead, he closed the small distance between them and slapped the piece of duct tape he was holding over the cut on Deku’s forehead, pressing down on it.

Deku hissed loudly in surprise and pain.

“*Ouch*! What are you *doing*?!”, he protested, voice squeaky, instinctively trying to push Katsuki’s hand away from his face. It didn’t work.

“I’m stopping you from bleeding to death”, Katsuki explained simply, nonchalantly.

He let go of Deku's forehead abruptly, earning another hiss from the boy. Grabbing the tape roll from beneath his armpit, Katsuki pulled out another piece, cut it off with his teeth, and placed the roll under his armpit again, exactly like the first time, with the same level of calm. Then, he slapped the second piece of duct tape on Deku's forehead without warning again, securing the first piece firmly in place and pressing down on his forehead even harder than before.

"Ouch, *Kacchan*!", Deku hissed louder, grabbing at Katsuki's wrist and trying to pull his hand away once again. Katsuki didn't even flinch.

"I don't exactly have a fucking first aid kit here, so that will have to do until we manage to find you some proper help", he explained, giving Deku's forehead one final press before he let go with a light push. "It's not ideal, but at least it will stanch the bleeding before you keel over. Press your hand to it", he instructed firmly.

Then, he turned on his heels and walked back towards Jirou without another word.

Deku stayed where he was for a moment, pressing one hesitant hand to his duct-taped forehead as instructed, before making a move to follow Katsuki, who had gone back to squatting down on the floor beside their friend.

"You… didn't have to do that", Izuku said quietly as he approached them, but the defiance in his voice had deflated a little.

"If you could see your shitty face, you wouldn't be saying that", Katsuki said simply, grumpily, not looking at him.

"That's – That's not what I meant", Izuku protested, but his voice was too low and awkward for Katsuki to hear.

Instead of paying Deku any attention now that he wasn't under the imminent threat of passing out from blood loss (even though he was still pretty fucking worried about the concussion), Katsuki went back to focusing on Jirou, who was still out cold. The girl didn't even flinch when he yanked the tape away from her mouth, which was concerning, because that shit *had* to hurt. Katsuki shook her shoulder once, twice; he tapped her cheek and downright slapped it, but she didn't rouse. She didn't even *twitch*.

"I – I think they drugged her", Deku provided, noticing Katsuki's increasing sense of urgency as he failed to awaken his friend. Katsuki craned his head to glare at him, hating that Deku had reached the exact same conclusion as he did, for some reason.

Also, Deku looked messed up like that, half of his face covered in drying blood, two pieces of duct tape glued to his forehead to form an X, and a hand pressing down on the result of that bloody mess while he stared down at Katsuki with glassy eyes.

When Katsuki had thought Deku could be a double or a fake, those things hadn't bothered him so much, but now that he knew this was real Deku with real blood and a real concussion… The sight made him feel ~~scared~~ irritated.

“You gonna elaborate on that?”, he urged, raising his eyebrows when Deku didn’t continue. He had already considered that Jirou could have been drugged, but he needed Deku to keep turning the gears of that brain of his before the concussion took the best of him. Even if that meant forcing the nerd to talk about shit he already knew.

“I don’t know –“, Deku swallowed dry, clearly embarrassed by his own slowness. “I tried talking to her, but she just wouldn’t wake up… And – And I woke up faster than she did, but I was captured *after* her, so – I thought they could have… Uh…”, he stuttered.

“Who’s *they*, Deku?”, Katsuki cut him off and asked urgently, face serious.

His heart was racing inside his chest, even if he was trying his best to ignore it and keep his head cool for Deku’s sake. The last thing the concussed idiot with a martyr complex needed on that moment was for Katsuki to have a full-on freak out and make him have ideas about taking control of the situation.

(As if he even could.)

But now that he had a little time to process everything that was happening to them – now that he was failing to wake Jirou up no matter what he did; now that he actually *thought* about the fact that the villain could have bashed Deku’s head in a bit too strongly and killed him on the spot, or that someone could have snapped Jirou’s neck and left her body on the deposit, or that they were in actual, real life-threatening *danger* –, he was having a really hard time keeping it together, no matter how much he was forcing himself to *focus, focus, focus*.

Because holy fuck, he had been right. They really *were* under attack. He hadn’t been making shit up. He hadn’t been responding to *trauma* or any of that shit Doctor Matsuo thought. Sure, maybe he overreacted a bit by thinking Deku was a double, but other than that, he had been mostly correct all along. They were actually in danger, it wasn’t an exaggeration, and for what must have been the first time ever, he didn’t have any room in his chest to feel smug about having been right all along.

Because they were not out of the woods. He couldn’t afford to lose his shit just yet – he would have to save the freak out session for later. He would have to keep a straight face and take control of the situation, because he was clearly the only one fit to be in charge on that moment. He would have to overcome his own rising sense of fear if he wanted to save these assholes.

“I d-don’t know”, Deku shook his head nervously, clearly worried.

“You don’t fucking *know*?”, Katsuki pressed, annoyed. He couldn’t work with fucking uncertainties. He needed to have *facts*. “*Think*, Deku. Didn’t anyone look familiar or anything?”

Izuku swallowed dry.

“I – I didn’t recognize anyone. I don’t think they’re with the League, they – they didn’t *look* familiar. Maybe they’re another group. All I know is I followed Jirou-san after she was taken, and then I got captured and ended up here. Do – Do you think this is an attack?”

“Of *course* this is an –!“, Katsuki exploded, but got a hold of himself before he could finish.

He took a deep breath and closed his eyes for a brief moment to regain his calm, one hand on his hip and the other pinching the bridge of his nose.

“Look”, he sighed, glaring at Deku and gesturing at him. “They were locking up the auditorium when I got out. You are clearly concussed and they tied you and Ears up. I don’t know if this whole museum shit was a scam from the beginning of it only happened to be hijacked by some douchebag villains today, but yes, Deku, this is clearly an attack. Why else would they knock you out and tie you up down here just for getting *lost in a building*?”

Izuku blinked at him but nodded, still serious, looking like he was trying his hardest to keep up despite his head injury.

“No, yes, I mean... I think he, uh. I think he must have recognized me. That’s why he knocked me out. Either from the Sports Festival, or from… uh…”

He didn’t have to finish. Katsuki knew what he was thinking.

The villain attack. Even if UA tried its best to keep it as secretive as possible – and the avoidance of media coverage was exactly why Katsuki took so long to figure out what was truly going on with Deku’s soul, by the way –, they both knew word had gotten out about Deku’s predicament. A UA student, attacked by a villain during a training session and sent to a fucking coma that almost costed him his life.

Shit.

Sometimes Katsuki forgot how big their lives were becoming – how big their influence in the outside world was bound to be. In a few years, he and Deku would be famous heroes. Their names and faces would be known by all. There would be articles about them on the internet. Anyone would be able to google them and find details about their lives. They would become even bigger targets. If they were already going through hell while they were just stupid students, Katsuki could only imagine the sort of threat they would face once they were pros.

The thought excited and scared him at the same time. Being the number one hero was exactly what he was aiming for his whole life – and he knew that becoming that, and holding that title, didn’t come without sacrifices. The fame, the annoying paparazzi, the invasion of his privacy, the exposition, and all the downsides of it – Katsuki knew those things were bound to happen. And those were sacrifices he was willing to make.

But now, he also knew there was more in the line than just winning or losing when it came to climbing his way to the top. And the *losing* part wasn’t exactly easy to deal with.

He knew that now. From experience.

His stomach churned.

And it wasn’t like he’d be able to protect Deku from all the dangers they would face once they became pros, and it wasn’t like he would ever be stupid enough to think that Deku

would give up his dream of becoming a hero just for the sake of Katsuki's peace of mind. The realization that either of them they could drop dead beyond repair at any given moment made the hairs on Katsuki's arms stand up and his heart beat even faster, and the sudden knowledge that keeping Deku safe was something *completely* out of his control – hence the fucking gash on his forehead and the fact that he had been unconscious at a villain's hand's just minutes ago – was making it hard(er) to catch his breath.

When did he lose his confidence? When did he lose his certainty that he would definitely *win* and overcome whatever trouble that appeared in front of him? Why did he lose his courage, why was he freaking out like a scared quirkless baby?

Was it because he lost Deku?

Ok, all right, one thing at the time. He needed to *focus.* No use in fucking worrying about the damn future – it was clearly out of his control, if his awkward, unplanned reunion with Deku after literal months of ignoring each other was anything to go by. What he *needed* to worry about was the present, and how to get out of this shitty tight spot.

He could do this. He was Bakugou fucking Katsuki, he was training to be a hero, he would become the one who surpassed All Might. He could do this. He had this. All he had to do was focus, breathe, and get it together before shitty Deku figured out he was about to have a fucking breakdown. He could *do* this. He didn't need to fear death, because dying wasn't an option.

(He kept repeating those words inside his head like a mantra. They served to calm him down a bit, and regain some of his confidence back.)

All right. Deku was concussed, Ears was out of commission. Katsuki was the only one fit to help these losers and the losers upstairs, who probably still didn't know any better about what was happening. And he could do this, because he was amazing, and because he would become number one, and the number one hero didn't have freak out sessions while kneeling on the dusty floor of a shitty museum's deposit room. The number one hero smiled in front of adversity and overcame it, so that was what he was going to do. He could deal with the panic and the heavy, unexpected awareness of his own mortality later, when they weren't under attack.

He supposed he had never felt this sort of insecurity before because he had never *lost* before – not until he saw Deku's dead face lying against his chest, not until he watched as his heart stopped beating and he choked on his own blood. He had never feared death because he had never faced it, not for real, not like *that* – and he had stupidly thought he was incapable of ever losing, like a dumb child who thinks they can take on the world without as much as a scratch. Out of a sudden, his mantra of "dying isn't an option" sounded childish and naïve – and it stopped working altogether.

Death *was* an option. A very real one, as Deku had proved twice over. And to know that – to be so intimate with that – made his so far unfaltering confidence…

Falter.

Katsuki knew he was amazing and a better-than-average student, but he also knew better, now, than to expect he'd be so amazing as to defeat *death*. And now that he'd been lucky enough to escape from it twice – well, Deku's death, at least – he also knew better than to expect he'd be as lucky on a third time.

Which was why he needed to prevent a third time from ever happening again, and fucking great, there he was back at *digressing*. So much for criticizing Deku, eh?

Ok, first things first. One: he could think about all this shit later and maybe even talk to Doctor Matsuo about it (if he felt like it). His first priority was taking Deku and Ears out of that deposit before the villains came back, and direct them somewhere safe where they could call the pros.

Two: after they were both secure, he had to find a way to deal with whatever shit that was about to go down on the auditorium while the pros didn't arrive, because there was *no way* some random villains had just kidnapped two students over nothing unless they had a bigger plan, and they hadn't been locking the shitty auditorium down for no reason –

"Uh, Kacchan…?", Deku said, calling his attention and breaking him away from his thoughts.

"*What*?", Katsuki responded sharply, feeling annoyed at the interruption – just when he was finally getting his urgent thoughts in order.

"Nothing", Deku blinked at him. "It's just… You've been glaring at Jirou-san in silence for a long while now", he pointed out.

Katsuki squinted in anger. He really had, hadn't he?

Three: stop wasting his fucking time with useless shit and *make a damn move* already before it's too late.

"Are – Are you… ok?", Deku frowned, concerned, when Katsuki didn't answer. Katsuki scoffed, even more annoyed.

"Just because I don't mutter my ass off while I'm thinking like you do, doesn't mean I'm *not* thinking", he pointed out, sounding a bit too defensive.

Katsuki got back to his feet and pulled the unconscious Jirou along with him, like he had done to Deku. When she rolled against him limply, Katsuki easily picked the small girl up and threw her body over both his shoulders, holding her arms and legs against his chest. She was light, small, and easy to carry, thanks to the intensive daily training Katsuki had going on in his routine.

"Let's get going", he announced, already starting to march away from the shelves and towards the door.

Deku blinked at him, surprised by the way they had suddenly gone from "staring in silence at Jirou's unconscious form with a pensive look for a long time" to "let's skedaddle the hell out

of here right away".

"Ok…?", he complied hesitantly, following Katsuki. "But where? What's the plan?"

Katsuki closed his eyes briefly and counted to ten.

"Listen, Deku, I'm not gonna keep fucking repeating myself. You're concussed, and even if you weren't, I would still be the one in char–"

"Wait", Deku interrupted him, raising a warning hand. His already low tone got even lower, and he was pointing Katsuki's phone's flashlight towards a far corner of the deposit room.

Katsuki glared at the darkness, then back at him.

"What?", he asked when Deku didn't say or do anything, lowering his voice further as well.

"Do you see that?", Deku frowned. Katsuki scoffed.

"See what?", he squinted. The deposit room was large and dark, and the flashlight of his phone only ranged so far.

"Shh", Deku interrupted him again, raising a finger at him.

Katsuki saw red.

"Who the *fuck* do you think you're *shushing* –", he whispered, abrasive.

"Shh!", Deku shushed again, more urgent this time. "I think…", he turned to meet his eyes. "I think someone else is there", Deku whispered.

Katsuki's whole body immediately assumed a defensive stance that mirrored Deku's, as if it was his second nature. Without having to think about it, he carefully placed Jirou back down on the floor, where she'd be safer, and placed himself between Deku and the darkness.

He snatched the phone away from Deku's hand, aiming it properly at the spot they had been staring at. He tried to see what he was seeing, hear what he was hearing (even if it was a lost cause), and as he slowly paced towards the dark corner of the room, eyes sharp with attention and vaguely aware of Deku following him close, he spotted it.

A lump on the floor. A guy, lying on his side, back turned to them, hands and ankles tied up.

It wasn't a villain. It was another person, another kidnapped person. Unconscious, just like Ears. Katsuki hadn't noticed him there before because of how far off his body had been dropped at – and with the poor illumination of the room, he had been hidden in shadows. Deku had probably spotted him out of sheer luck, by waving the phone with the flashlight on as he walked or something.

Ok. This was getting too real, too fast. And Katsuki absolutely *hated* it.

This wasn't in his plans. He hadn't included this guy in his plan of escape, and now he would have to rethink that whole shit because it wasn't like he couldn't leave whoever this fucker was behind, but his mobility would be compromised if he was forced to carry two people *and* watch out for their safety at the same time –

"Kacchan –!", Deku whispered urgently, grabbing his wrist and trying to warn him about something.

Several things happened at once.

First, Deku grabbed the phone (whose flashlight was still on) from Katsuki's hand, pulled the brim of Katsuki's pants and shoved the device inside his underwear. Which, yeah, ok, was definitely a turn of events Katsuki did *not* see coming, ever. *Ever.*

He didn't really have the time to think about that or to react in any way, though, because then, before Katsuki could turn around to look at Deku, or before he could even think about the fact that Deku had just *shoved his fucking hand inside his boxers,* white light emerged from the front door, contrasting sharply with the dim yellow of the deposit's interior.

Someone had opened the door.

Someone was entering the room.

Ok. Now Katsuki understood why Deku had shoved the phone with the flashlight on inside his pants. Unlocking the screen in order to turn the light off would take too much time, and shoving it inside his pocket wouldn't be enough to prevent the light from shining through the fabric.

(Still... What the fuck.)

(But at least Deku hadn't shoved the phone inside his *own* boxers. That would make for an awkward reunion with his phone.)

Thankfully, they had both been away from the door when it opened, too busy checking on the unconscious guy at the corner. And double thankfully, Deku had overheard the person arriving – something Katsuki had to admit he couldn't do – and eliminated the beaming fucking source of light that would have immediately called the villain's attention just in time. Which meant they hadn't been spotted in the shadows.

Yet.

Katsuki used his free hand to grab Deku by the forearm and pulled him towards himself so they could shrink behind a large shelf and take cover before they were seen. They managed to hide just as the person stepped into the room, closing the door behind them.

Since the deposit was pretty silent, Katsuki could tell, despite his impaired hearing, that there was only one set of footsteps inside with them. The person – probably a villain – had come alone.

Katsuki didn't have much time to think or to plan. The whole expo had already gone to shit the moment they decided to go around kidnapping people – sorry to Hatsume and her babies, but there was no saving it. And it wasn't like he could go around exploding everything and be done with it – he didn't know how many villains he was facing off against, what their plan was, or what they were even doing to the attendees upstairs.

Katsuki needed to get Deku and Ears out of there and help the people in the auditorium, and in order to do that, at least until he was sure of what he was up against, he would need *stealth*. Exploding everything like he wanted to would just draw unwanted attention, which would make it even harder for him to win.

Which brought him back to his current dilemma. He could either try to play it safe and wait for the villain to leave the deposit room on his own – which he couldn't be sure would happen so soon, or at all –, or he could take the villain out as silently as possible, release Deku, Jirou and the other unconscious guy, and then carry on with his plan of getting them out and saving everyone.

Ok. Think. *Think.*

Ever since he arrived, he had been bothered by the sheer amount of effort it took those assholes to gather everyone in one place. Making the All Might expos, which were certain to attract more public, last for a limited amount of time; giving All Might souvenirs at the end of a shitty opening speech just to force people into attending; having an All Might-centric floor, everything – *everything* was meant to force the people who loved All Might into that place. Which meant a *whole fucking lot* of people would attend. Those who didn't love All Might (rare) but came in anyway would be a bonus, but there was still one common factor that connected all of the museum's visitors – their love for heroes.

Jirou's removal from the auditorium had clearly been thought-through, since the guy had knocked her out halfway to the deposit – they had already been planning on kidnapping her from the beginning. Which meant they didn't want someone with a sound quirk to be around – why?

Maybe they had feared Jirou would overhear something, or figure out there was something weird happening by using her quirk. He couldn't be sure. But to target Jirou meant they knew what her quirk was, which on its own turn meant they knew *her*.

She hadn't called too much attention on the Sports Festival, which meant she had been watched and/or spied on by these villains. The fact that Yaoyorozu recognized one of the guys as the Sound Quirk Dude from the park – the one who caused his entire fight with Deku, by the way – indicated that not only did they spy on Jirou, but they also probably spied on other students from UA. Hence why Deku had a gash on his forehead and why whoever-that-unconscious-guy-was had been caught as well.

They had been watching them. They had been studying them, analyzing them, for fuck knows how long.

Fuck knows what they knew.

Fuck knows what they would *do*.

Every single one of his friends upstairs, at the auditorium, could be a potential target, and these villains probably knew exactly what they would do to try and defend themselves. They probably knew all about their quirks, and how to counter-attack – hence how they had picked off Jirou right away. And his friends would be helpless up there, even now that Katsuki figured it all out, because *none of them had any phone reception*. And Jirou – the one who could probably send out a cry for help using her loud sound quirk and get the pros to come help – was out of commission.

Katsuki couldn't believe he was actively *wishing* there had been a meet & greet with the pros in that godforsaken building.

He couldn't call his friends. He couldn't let them know they were in danger. He couldn't let them know Ears was out of commission and Deku was concussed and there was an *ongoing attack* happening, or about to happen, or on its way. He couldn't call the fucking *pros*.

He had to do this on his own. And that had never been a problem before but – god, what the fuck would he do if Ears died on him? If *Deku* died? He absolutely needed to ensure their safety. He absolutely needed to *win.* There was no other option. He needed to ensure he wouldn't possibly fail and lose to those D-listers, he needed to ensure he would rescue everyone. He needed to ensure he would *win*.

Win, so he could *save*.

Ok. He could do this. He was good, he was awesome, he would become the number one hero who surpassed All Might. He could take this bunch of idiot villains down and rescue everyone. He could do this, he was *Bakugou Katsuki*. He already had his fair share of pathetic defeats, so now it was about time he conquered some more victories for his list.

Ok, time for basic logic. If the villains thought the people they had restrained were still harmlessly tied down and contained at the deposit, they wouldn't worry or send anyone else downstairs to check on them. That would buy Katsuki more time – the last thing he needed while trying to rescue everyone upstairs was to be tailed by these assholes, even if he was pretty sure there were people looking for him already. There was no way that creepy security guard from the auditorium didn't notice he never returned from his trip to the bathroom after he put on such a scene.

But for the villains to think the people they had captured were still trapped and with no need for further intervention, Katsuki couldn't afford any leaks. Which meant he couldn't let the villain see them. And, in case the villain saw them, he couldn't let him leave, lest he tell his villain buddies.

Actually… Now that Katsuki thought about it, they *definitely* couldn't let the villain leave.

Because he had untied Jirou. And Katsuki had carried her body, and dropped it off somewhere different. And Deku was also untied and gone. There was no way the guy wouldn't notice that.

Shit.

This whole stream of thoughts only took Katsuki's analytical brain a couple of seconds. And, by the time the villain crouched down next to the unconscious Jirou with a frown on his face, noticing that her bindings and tape were gone, he had already decided what to do.

Ignoring Deku's attempt to grab his arm and not offering him a single glance or explanation, he jumped from behind the shelf.

Just as the villain heard him move and turned his head to look at him, Katsuki ran at his top speed and roundhouse kicked the guy's head before the asshole could even register what was happening to him or attempt to use his quirk.

It was over in a second: the man fell unconscious to the floor in an ungracious heap without as much as a yelp. Easy peasy.

(Katsuki wished he could have used one of his explosions, but he would take what he could get for now.)

He crouched down in front of the unconscious villain, feeling around for any weapons or tricks he could be hiding in his pockets. He didn't have any guns or knives, which indicated his quirk was probably a combative one and that he relied on it to defend himself. *Not that it was any fucking use, eh?*, Katsuki thought smugly.

All Katsuki found on him was a wallet, which was useless to him, a phone, which, as expected, had no reception, and a walkie talkie, which was one of the items he had been expecting to find. The villains would need a way to communicate with each other in the building without the phone reception, and the chance that Jirou could have overheard that or picked up the signal with her quirk was high.

Katsuki grabbed the walkie and turned it off before attaching it to his own belt. Maybe they could put some use to it in the future, maybe it would be useless to them – but what they *couldn't* risk was leaving the villain with that means of communication in there when he woke up.

Deku approached Katsuki and kneeled beside him, eyes fixed on the unconscious guy and a serious expression on his face. Katsuki turned his head to look at him, expecting a session of whining, but none came.

It took Deku a few moments to speak up.

"We should tie him up", he said shortly, not meeting Katsuki's eyes.

Then, he got to his feet and started looking around for the ropes that had been used to tie his own wrists. Simple as that.

Deku found the ropes he was looking for discarded next to Jirou, who was still out cold, and grabbed them. At the same time, Katsuki shoved his hand into his pants, then into his boxers, and retrieved his phone, which still had the flashlight turned on.

Deku blushed, but Katsuki pretended not to notice it. Instead, he silently unlocked the screen and turned the flashlight off – it would be safer if they resorted only to the light they had in the room, instead of shining a beacon that would easily give their location away should anyone else enter that room.

“We – We should also g-get out of here already” Deku added, clearly embarrassed, offering the ropes to Katsuki. “We don’t know what this guy’s quirk is; we might not be able to fight it on our own when he wakes up. The best thing to do now is restrain him and go get the pros’ help as soon as we can –“

“One”, Katsuki interrupted him abruptly, pointing a finger at him. “You ramble way too much for someone who’s concussed. Two –“, he reached up and basically yanked the ropes from Deku’s hand, beginning the process of tying the guy up, “– the kick I just gave this asshole’s head will buy me enough time to rescue everyone up there and bring the police all the way down here before he even *dreams* of waking up. And three –“, he emphasized the word with a harsh pull to tie the knot as tightly as possible, “– I already have a plan, so you don’t need to tell me yours. And that plan is helping you, Ears, and whoever that fuckface over there is to escape so that *you* can call the damn pros while I assess the situation upstairs”.

Izuku stared at him from the dark, incredulity taking over his face.

“You can’t be serious”, he said, sounding almost angry.

“You bet your ass I’m *dead* serious”.

Izuku glared.

“No?”, Izuku cut him off abruptly, pissed off. “You *can’t* be serious right now”.

“Do I look like I’m fucking joking, Deku?”, Katsuki snapped, his tone leaving no place for a discussion. He got to his feet and placed both hands on his hips, leaning in closer so that the nerd could see his glare in the darkness.

Tension. Growing.

They glared at each other, and Katsuki could feel it coming – he could *feel* they were about to enter the so dreaded self-preservation-themed territory. And he *hated* it – he hated it so much. They didn’t have the *time* for that shit. They needed to get out of there.

“Once I’m done tying this piece of shit up, we’ll get out of here”, Katsuki said, urgent, trying to show, just with his voice, that they were running on a tight schedule, “I’ll help you three out of the building, and you’ll find somewhere safe to take Ears and –“

“God, I can’t believe this”, Izuku scoffed again, shaking his head and clearly upset. “*Every* time I think you’re finally getting it, you go and you pull this off again!”

Katsuki scoffed back in disbelief, narrowing his eyes and trying hard to keep his cool. He needed to *focus* if he was getting out of there with –

“After all these months, you really learned *nothing*, did you, Kacchan?”, Deku added.

Yeah.

Yeah, ok, you know what? Fuck that. His focus be damned; he wouldn’t let Deku talk to him like that.

“Oh, I’m sorry, was there something for me to learn? Some *higher fucking lesson* I didn’t keep up with?”, Katsuki ironized, annoyed. “I couldn’t really catch that from the total amount of *0 conversations we’ve had in the past fucking semester*!”

And there it was. All the tension they both had accumulated in the past months – everything that was finally becoming too much to bear in silence.

And *fuck*, Katsuki realized. This was the first time he talked to Deku – actually talked – in *seven fucking months,* and they were already straight back to fighting. As if they were just picking up from where they’d left off.

And they were still stuck on the same fucking page of dissonance.

“Yeah? And whose fault is that?”, Deku retorted. “Whose *fault* is it we didn’t have any conversations, huh, Kacchan?”

“Don’t try to shove the fucking blame on me, you damn nerd!”, Katsuki barked, pointing a finger at his face. “You’re the one who didn’t tell me you were pissed, and for fucking *months*! How was I supposed to fucking know what you were feeling?! And then one day, out of *nowhere*, you decide you’ve had enough and start acting like I was the worst person in the entire *fucking* world, and you must have thought I was what? Some sort of fucking mind reader or something? What the *hell* did you expect from me? Huh, Deku?!”

“I expected you not to call me the *one thing* I asked you not to! That shouldn’t need saying! And I expected you not to keep doing the same thing you did to me for years, especially because you said you were trying to do better! Especially after I came clean with you! Especially after *you* were the one who made me quirkless again!”

“I needed you to take a fucking breather, and you weren’t *listening* to me! Like you always fucking do! What was I supposed to do, just step aside and let you fucking die?”

“Are you serious right now? *I’m* the one who doesn’t listen? When all you do is yell and talk over people? Breaking news, Kacchan, just because your voice is louder doesn’t mean you won the argument!”

“And yet you’re the asshole who keeps refusing to listen to what I tell you, even if I scream it at your face!”

“You refuse to listen to what I tell you, too! What are you even talking about?!”

“I’m talking about all the fucking times I told you I care about your dumb ass! About all the times I told you about how seeing you die fucked me up, about how it made me rethink everything I ever thought about you during our fucking childhood! I’m talking about all the

times I made it more than clear enough I didn't want to *lose* you again, about how I fucking did something I hated just so I could save your shitty life, and how you keep fucking acting like I did it on purpose, when all I was trying to do was keep you from kicking the bucket! And how you got fucking *mad* at me even though you never told me that what I was doing was pissing you off!"

Izuku was silent for once, breathing hard and staring at Katsuki with a mix of hurt and anger.

It was a while before he responded.

"And I'm talking about all the times I told you I felt helpless", Izuku said, voice thick and raw. "About the times I confided in you, despite everything I went through as a kid, and about the times I told you how terrible it made me feel that I was sick, and weak, and *useless*. It's about the times I told you I hated being treated differently, and I hated not being able to do anything, because that's how I've felt my whole life. Before U.A. When we were kids. Even if I never let you actually put me down with the stuff you said to me, even if I kept on pushing and trying my best despite that, the fear that I'd amount to nothing would *always* nag at the back of my head, it would always be there, and it was like this until All Might told me I could be a hero too. And guess what? It's still here", he sniffed, shaking his head.

A pause.

"It's still here. The fear that I'm not enough, that I can't accomplish anything without other people's help, that I'm just a *deku*, not a deku that means "I can do it", but a deku that means "useless", like you intended to. And I told you about all that, and about my fear of not being a good hero because of what happened, and you *still* treated me like I was nothing anyway. Like I was a – a *deku*, even if you didn't even know what the threat was. You didn't even know if there was something I could do to help, and you had already discarded me. Like you've been doing all my life".

Katsuki glared at him. Izuku glared back, sniffing some more. Katsuki didn't need light to know there were tears in Izuku's eyes.

"I can't bear being discarded by you anymore, Kacchan", he continued. "I've been putting up with it for too long. And now that we're finally doing better – that we *were* finally doing better… It *hurts.* More than it did before. Because before, you were always angry, always harsh, always mean. You always acted like you hated me. And I had accepted that. I knew how to deal with that, I could take that. I could live with your hatred of me. But with this…", he shook his head. "I don't know what to expect. And – and to have the tiniest bit of hope, only to have it torn away from me all over again, to hope that maybe you feel like I feel, and admire me like I've always admired you, to hope that maybe, just maybe, you think of me as highly as I think of you, and then to find out that you don't, that you still see me as useless and as worthless and as *weak*, it… It just hurts too much", he concluded, running the back at his hand at his nose.

Izuku sniffed, looking away.

"Before, I could bear this behavior, because it was the only one that I ever knew. The only one you *let* me know. The only one I could *get.* But after you were finally being nice to me,

after we were finally becoming friends… I didn't want us to go back to what we had before. All the hatred and the mistrust and the distance and the accusations. But you *did*. You kept going back and forth, you kept alternating between being nice and being harsh, and it was confusing, and it *hurt.* And I shouldn't have waited so long to tell you that, but I did, and I'm sorry for that, but not for anything else. I'm *not* sorry for feeling hurt and realizing I don't deserve to feel hurt all the time, no matter how many times I've let other people down. And I'm not saying that – that I want you to change into someone who is caring and gentle and tender all the time, because that wouldn't be *Kacchan*. All I wanted was for you to l–", he swallowed dry, hesitant.

A pause. Tense, and full of meaning. Katsuki could almost hear the rest of the sentence in his head, for some reason.

"All I wanted was for you to be proud of me", Deku concluded, and that was not what Katsuki had expected.

He stared at Deku for a moment before he scoffed, clicking his tongue.

"You know what hurts more than all that shit, Deku?", he said before he could really think about it, voice hoarse.

He knew he'd be able to see Deku's point if he tried, but he *wanted* to be angry. It felt fair. He wanted to be mad about all those months he spent suffering in silence because Deku didn't have the guts to be straight with him and just *tell him* all that shit he was saying now. He wanted to let all his feelings out, and this was the easiest way to do that – and most of all, he wanted Deku to *see* that he didn't have such a great fucking time either. That living with the memories and the nightmares and the guilt of having made him quirkless again wasn't exactly a stroll in the park. That he had suffered, too, every time Deku misinterpreted the actions had learned how to read so well during his time as a ghost, or acted like Katsuki was still that bratty, tactless piece of shit he had grown up with.

"Having to watch you die", Katsuki continued, voice raw. "Over, and over, and *over again*. Without being able to do anything to stop it. Without being able to *save* you. And the one time I *can* do something to save you, is by doing something I know will *hurt* you. Like what I did back at the hospital. Like what I did back at the park".

Izuku stared at him, an unreadable expression on his moist face.

"I knew that taking your quirk would hurt you. And I knew that calling you quirkless would hurt you. And I did those things anyway, not because I wanted you to suffer, but because I knew that with you it's all or nothing. You'll hurt yourself and you'll break your bones for fucking *sport*. Asking you politely to find some fucking sense and *not die* wasn't working, so I did what I had to do. I pushed you away, like I've been doing for years, because you're fucking stubborn, and you're fucking *crazy*, you'll just do whatever you can to get yourself killed. You'll put other people's lives in front of yours, and other people's needs in front of yours, and you've been doing that for years, and I *know* you. And I know – I learned – how to react to that. I learned that the only thing that makes you stop when you're being relentless, and the only thing that makes you jump into action when you're terrified – is me. And I used that. Now you go and tell me what sort of fucking hero that makes me, huh?", he

scoffed in self-deprecation. “The only way I can save your life without failing like a weak, pathetic loser and having you die on me is by making you suffer. Is by *hurting* you. And yeah, it fucking sucks. For you, and for me, but mostly for you. But at this point, I’d rather have you spend the rest of your shitty days mad at me then having you die *again*”.

Izuku stared at him, raw emotion written all over his face.

None of them said anything for a while, both of them too caught up in their feelings and in their thoughts about each other’s words.

Silence stretched uncomfortably.

“We’ve already wasted too much time on this shitty talk”, Katsuki said eventually, angry, not meeting Deku’s eyes. With a sniff, he turned his back on him and crouched down beside the villain again.

He made sure the villain’s arms and legs were bound securely by tight knots – not the wimpy, lax ones from which Deku had easily escaped – before he got back to his feet, looking around.

“We need to make a move before someone else arrives. We’re already lucky no one else did. And we can sit and talk about this whole touchy-feely shit once we’re done saving our friends”.

Izuku continued to stare at him for a moment, apparently too taken aback to speak, before swallowing dry and nodding.

“You – You’re right. We can talk about this later”, he agreed, sounding sober.

Katsuki dragged the unconscious villain towards the farthest wall in the deposit room, the one that was the most covered in shadows, and left him propped up there. Then, he went back and picked Jirou up again, throwing her over one shoulder. He approached the other victim, who was still unconscious by the corner, and Deku followed him close behind.

Deku knelt beside the unconscious man and began the process of unfastening his bindings and removing the duct tape from his face, something they hadn’t had the time to do before the villain’s arrival and that Katsuki couldn’t currently do because he was holding Jirou. *Well, at least he’ll feel useful for once*, Katsuki’s brain supplied.

Deku gently took the guy’s pulse and checked him over in the dim light before craning his neck to look up at Katsuki.

“He seems to be drugged, too”, Deku stated. “There’s no signs of violence. I can’t see if there’s a needle mark, but there wasn’t one on Jirou-san. I can’t feel any lumps on his neck or on his arms, either. It *could* have been a gas, or something like chloroform, but I believe if that was the case, they would be waking up by now. Also, I can’t smell anything weird on them”.

Katsuki watched him, waiting for the words he knew would come.

~~(Unless he was mistaken again –)~~

“It’s safer if we assume a quirk caused this”, Deku concluded, waiting for a reaction. He sounded more aware and more sober than a few moments before, but from the way he was half-sagging on the floor, Katsuki could tell his concussion was still pretty much holding him back.

A few seconds passed before Katsuki nodded at Deku with a pensive look on his face. That conclusion made sense.

“And you weren’t captured by this guy with the Drugging Quirk”, Katsuki complemented. “Otherwise, you wouldn’t be awake with your head bleeding all over the place”, he nodded at the tape still covering Izuku’s cut. “He could have just drugged you too”.

“Yes”, Izuku nodded pensively. He spared the unconscious villain Katsuki had tied up a quick glance. “And the guy who captured me wasn’t that one. He wasn’t the one with Jirou-san in the elevator, either”.

“I know that”.

“So this means we’re dealing with that guy”, he pointed at the tied-up villain, “the guy with the Drug Quirk, *and* the guy who took Jirou-san”.

“Probably more, Deku”, Katsuki pointed out, serious, a hint of disapproval in his voice. “They wouldn’t be going through the trouble of kidnapping people and tying them up down here unless they had something big planned. And you can’t have something big planned in a building like this one with just three D-listers as backup”.

Izuku nodded hesitantly, frowning.

“Jirou-san’s sound quirk”, he said. “That’s why they took her out. She could have overheard something and ruined their plans before they even started. And then they took *me* out, because I noticed she’d been taken and because they probably knew I was a trouble magnet. This guy probably saw something suspicious, too”, he nodded at Whatshisname.

“Yeah”, Katsuki nodded. “Also, the girl with the creation quirk told me that one of the guys who was working on the auditorium’s maintenance looked like the asshole from the park”, Katsuki provided.

“The park?”, Izuku frowned, confused.

“Yeah. The one whose quirk interfered with Ears’ and caused the explosion sound”, he said, not meeting Izuku’s eyes.

Great. Precisely the subject he *didn’t* want to talk about.

“Oh”, Izuku said, sounding surprised and a bit awkward.

A pause. Katsuki wanted to feel smug about the fact that Deku was *probably* realizing Katsuki had been right all along for holding him back that day. But he didn’t really have the

heart for that, not after their discussion.

“So… They’ve been watching us?”, Deku concluded, sounding nervous.

Katsuki scoffed, glaring at Izuku.

“Of fucking *course* they’ve been watching us, shitty Deku. How else would they know about Ears’ quirk?”, he snapped, impatient.

Izuku looked away, not responding. And for fuck’s sake, it wasn’t like Katsuki was *trying* to be rude to him, it was just… Ugh.

He didn’t really have the patience to deal with a concussed Deku who couldn’t keep up with him. He didn’t really have the patience to deal with *anything* at all in that moment, really. They just needed to get out of there, soon, and that number of questions wasn’t giving them any more extra time.

But Deku was concussed. And confused. The least Katsuki could do was… Well. Offer him some light, instead of snapping at him. Just this once, just to make up for the whole “quirkless” thing.

Katsuki sighed, deflating. He ran a tired hand over his face.

“How’s your concussion?”, he asked, genuinely concerned. He needed to know what he was dealing with, and how much of his help Deku would require – not that he expected the nerd to be honest about that.

“It’s fine”, Izuku said shortly, not looking at him and sounding serious. “So, back to the quirk”, he added sternly, back to business. “I didn’t see anything like a cloud of smoke or gas when Jirou-san entered the elevator with the guy. If this is really quirk related, it’s not like Midnight sensei’s quirk. And if it’s not airborne and not injectable, that means it can only happen through physical touch. It *could* be like Shinsou-kun’s quirk – maybe it has to do with giving the person a command like ‘sleep’ or something like that –, but I don’t think that’s the case. Skin-contact quirks are more recurrent, statistically speaking”.

“Yeah, that sounds about right”, Katsuki nodded, serious. The praise earned a weird look from Izuku. “So, we’d better watch out and not let any of those villains touch us directly, since we don’t know which one of them has the drug quirk”.

“Yes. That’d be wise”, Izuku agreed, nodding.

“Cool”, Katsuki nodded back, a serious look on his face. “Shouldn’t be a problem to me”.

Then, unceremoniously, Katsuki bent over and picked Whatshisname up, throwing his unconscious body over his spare shoulder like a sack of potatoes whereas Jirou occupied his other one.

“Kacchan!”, Deku protested, surprised.

“What?”, Katsuki stared at him with an impatient look, hoisting both Jirou and Whatshisname up with nothing more than a grunt. “You’re not gonna convince me to let you carry one of them, so give up”.

Izuku scoffed and looked annoyed, but he trailed after Katsuki anyway as he headed to the door.

“This isn’t even an ego thing, Kacchan”, he commented, bitter. “It’d just be making things easier, on both of us”.

“You said it yourself more than once that I don’t like to have things easy, so cut it”, Katsuki retorted, not looking at him. “And let’s be real – it’s *always* an ego thing when it comes to us”.

Izuku was silent for a few seconds. Then, he stepped directly in front of Katsuki, blocking his way, looking at him.

Katsuki tilted his head to the side, waiting for Deku to make a fucking move.

“After all these years”, Izuku commented, melancholic. “You still see me as lesser, don’t you?”

Katsuki scoffed.

“See? Ego thing”.

Izuku sighed. Katsuki tried to walk past him, but Izuku stepped into his way once again.

Katsuki glared at him. Izuku glared back.

“I’m being serious”, Izuku said.

“So am I”, Katsuki retorted.

“The fact that you’re not denying it just proves –“

“I’m *not* going to have this discussion with you, as much as I’m *dying* to kick your fucking ass right now”, Katsuki cut him off abruptly, angry. “We agreed to talk about this shit later, so we’ll talk about this shit later”.

“We will, but you’re being a thickhead right now”, Deku talked back to him.

“Did you mean a *dickhead*?”, Katsuki snorted. “Because if you did, that counts as a swear–“

“I meant someone whose head is *thick*, because you insist on slowing yourself down by carrying two bodies instead of sharing the weight with me and optimizing your mobility”, Izuku pointed out, stern.

Katsuki didn’t even have the time to feel anything about the fact that his inside joke about Deku’s swearing had flown over the nerd’s head, because Deku was damn serious.

(And also right. But he couldn't admit that.)

"Deku –"

"It's not an ego thing", the boy interrupted. "I'm just trying to help you. This isn't some explosion in the park, Kacchan, this is an actual villain attack, and our friends could be in danger. You shouldn't do this on your own".

Katsuki stared at him for a few moments that felt like an eternity.

"Go see if you can find another door. We need to get out of here before someone else arrives, and I'd rather have more than one exit plan", he settled for ordering, not complying to Deku's wishes.

As much as Deku was right about Katsuki doing everything on his own, he was still wrong about being able to help, because he was fucking concussed and about to keel over any second now. Carrying extra weight wouldn't do wonders for his state, and he didn't need to over-exert himself when Katsuki was fit to do the carrying.

Izuku looked like he wanted to argue, but he bit his lower lip and averted Katsuki's gaze instead.

"Ever since I first woke up, someone came and went three times. The first time I was still groggy, the second time I was a bit more conscious but still tied up. I pretended to be passed out, but no one even checked on me. And by the third time I was already free and I almost hit you with a crowbar", he said, a bit too smug. "But all those times, they only ever used this door", Deku nodded at the front door. "I don't know if it was the same person on the first two times, but I don't think there's another exit".

"And there won't be any windows 'cause we're underground", Katsuki huffed, looking around and trying to think. "*Fine*. We'll have to go through this door, but that will mean we will step out into a fucking hall that will leave us cornered for a few meters, at least until we reach the intersection and the emergency stairs. We might be spotted before we get there".

"And what if we are spotted?"

"Then we fight. As silently as possible, since we don't really need any extra eyes on us for now".

"And then what?", Izuku asked, serious.

"Then we'll find a way for you to leave the damn building with Ears and Whatshisname, get them to safety, and call the fucking pros while I figure out whatever the hell it is they're doing upstairs and beat their ass if it comes to it", Katsuki said.

"Why don't we call the pros right now?", Izuku frowned, earning an eye roll from Katsuki.

"They jammed the signal. There's no reception in the whole building".

Izuku didn't seem pleased by that piece of information, but he nodded, worrying at his lower lip.

"Don't look so fucking bitter. Once you're out you'll finally get to carry your poor little rescue victims like you so want to", Katsuki ironized, adjusting the two unresponsive bodies he was carrying on his shoulders so that he could grab the handle on the door. "I just hope you're as ready for that as you seem to think you are. They're pretty fucking heavy".

"Don't talk like that", Izuku protested, but it sounded half-hearted.

"Be ready", Katsuki warned. "Once I open this damn door, we'll have to make a run to the stairs, but we need to be fucking quiet", Katsuki instructed.

Once upon a time, when he was younger and less experienced, Katsuki might have burst out of the damn room by kicking the door and causing explosions as loudly as he could in order to attract every single villain into his direction and challenge the fuckers. But now, he was different.

Now he knew he wasn't always infallible. He was still pretty fucking amazing, but he wasn't undefeatable. He knew that people could die. He knew that *Deku* could die. And so could his friends upstairs, and Ears, if he failed at protecting her while she couldn't do that herself.

There were lives at stake. This wasn't the time to pick up a fight with some random villain with no scruples as a way to boost his ego. This wasn't the time to prove himself. This was the time to strategize and try his best to achieve the best possible outcome, so that he could go the hell back upstairs and *then* kick the villain's ass. The only way he'd be able to win would be by being patient, silent, and careful – not his strongest suits, he'd admit, but that was what he'd been working so hard for, right?

Before he managed to opened the door, Deku held his arm. Katsuki turned to look at him.

"Wait", he said, eyes a bit unfocused and not looking at Katsuki. "Tell me the plan again".

Katsuki scoffed, shrugging away from Deku's hand. He was getting more and more worried about the nerd every time he displayed those unnerving signs of being concussed.

"I'll open the door, we'll get to the stairs, we'll get you out –"

"How?"

"Through the fucking first-floor window, then you'll drag Ears and this fucker to safety –"

"Where?"

Katsuki scowled at him. He was trying really hard to be patient with the concussed Deku, but being interrupted was *definitely* one of his pet-peeves.

"The nearest police station is less than a kilometer away", he said through gritted teeth. "Plus, you'll probably get your phone reception back before that, which means you can call for help".

“Ok, but what if there are villains sentinelling the building? I don’t have my quirk. If someone attacks me, I don’t think I’ll be able to defend Jirou-san, this guy, and myself. What if they see us leaving…?”

Katsuki’s scowl deepened.

“So *now* your sense of self-fucking-preservation kicks in, huh? When it’s just a guy with a sound quirk in the middle of a park you’re ready to plunge face-first to your death and complain when I forbid you to, but when I actually *need* you to do something in order to save lives you chicken out like a –“

“Can you *stop*?”, Izuku protested, sharp. He would have looked menacing, had it not been for the duct tape glued to his forehead. “I’m being serious. Like you said yourself, this attack was clearly planned, so it’s highly unlikely there *won’t* be someone out there watching out for people trying to come in or, especially, to come out! Since everyone should be at the auditorium!”

Izuku’s face fell.

“Wait”, he said, eyes wide from realization. They still seemed too glassy, Katsuki realized with a twitch of his stomach. “The auditorium. Everyone should be there”, Izuku pointed out, staring at him.

“What?”, Katsuki scowled in confusion.

“The *auditorium*”, Izuku repeated. “Everyone in the building is supposed to be there right now. That’s the best possible occasion to lock everyone in. So no one can get out”.

“Yeah, genius”, Katsuki scoffed. “Where do you think I’ll be going after I see your nerd-ass out?”

“But you said you got out. Did you do that before or after they closed it?”, Izuku frowned. Katsuki narrowed his eyes at him.

“Before. But there was a security guard at the door”.

“He tried to stop you?”

“Yeah. Which is why we need to get the fuck out of here already. They’ll probably notice I’m taking *way* too long in the fucking bathroom and send someone after me”.

“There might be people after you already”, Deku swallowed dry, shaking his head and looking away. Then, he looked at Katsuki again, seeming hurt. “And you really expect me to go away and leave you in here? All alone? When you don’t even know what’s happening up there?”

“It’s not like you can fucking –!”, Katsuki started, annoyed, but stopped himself with a sharp sigh before he could say anything he regretted. He closed his eyes for a brief moment, taking a deep, calming breath (which didn’t calm him down at all) before he glared at Deku again. “Listen, Deku. I have no idea what’s going on up there, but I’m not about to assume it’s

anything good, since they gave you a concussion, kidnapped and drugged two people, and locked them in a goddamn *basement*".

Izuku frowned.

"I'm not concussed anymore", he said, as if that was obvious. "I'm feeling better. I can help".

"Oh, yeah? Is that why you're swaying and asking me the same fucking things all over again?"

It was too dark inside the room to see if Deku had blushed or not, but Katsuki had a hunch.

"I'm – I'm not", he tried to defend himself, but it sounded weak to his own ears. "I'm just trying to plan things out so we can –"

"Let me fucking finish", Katsuki interrupted him, annoyed. "Even though I don't know what the hell is happening up there, I still have an advantage, which is: they don't know where I am. If I keep things this way, I can make it back to the top floor, enter the auditorium through the back door, catch the villains by surprise, and maybe our shitty friends will even manage to do something useful and help me immobilize them while your nerdy ass calls the police and gets the pros here. Is the plan clear?"

Izuku gave him a look that was a mixture of concern and determination.

"Kacchan", he said, a bit more patiently than he had sounded a moment before. Almost… apologetic. "I can't just leave you here".

"Deku", he said, not as patiently as the nerd but still trying his best. "You're not fucking useless. Ok? I shouldn't have told you that", he admitted, even though it felt like there was fire coursing through his veins as he spat out the words. "But you're still…", he hesitated.

He decided not to use that word anymore.

"You don't have your quirk. Which means you could die if you try to fight these villains, who clearly don't give a shit about you or anyone since they had no problem drugging students", he gestured at the two bodies over his shoulders, which were getting heavier and heavier with each passing second.

Thank god for All Might's intense training that made him more fit for this, but *fuck* – Ears was definitely heavier than she looked after carrying her for a few minutes.

"Kacchan –"

"And I don't want to see you die again", Katsuki interrupted him. "So can you, for *fuck's sake*, just wake up and see reason for once in your life? Can you use that worm brain of yours to figure out that you'll help me a lot more by calling the fucking police instead of sticking around and getting yourself in danger?"

Izuku stared at him, the tiniest hint of comprehension appearing in his eyes.

“I’m not fucking looking down on you. I never did”, Katsuki added, trying to sound convincing.

Izuku paused, frowning.

“What?”

Katsuki scoffed. They really should be get going, but he knew he couldn’t just leave the subject at that. He knew Deku wouldn’t let him.

“The reason I hated you was because I thought *you* thought you were better than me. And I think that, deep down, *I* thought you were better than me, too. Otherwise I wouldn’t be so pissed about it, or about what you thought. And there was no way in hell I’d allow myself to be surpassed by someone like you”, he said, aware of the weight of his words.

Izuku stared at him.

“If I actually looked down on you, I wouldn’t even acknowledge your existence. But I did. I always did, even when I was forcing myself to ignore you. So I pushed you away. And the more I thought you were better – the more I thought you were *acting* like you were better –, the more it pissed me off. The more I wanted to beat you”.

Izuku looked surprised.

“So I’m not looking down on you, or thinking you’re lesser, or trying to undermine you, or whatever shit you’re thinking”, Katsuki concluded, glad that the room was dark and that Deku couldn’t see his face properly. “I don’t think you’re a liability. I’m just trying to keep your dumb ass safe. *And* I’m trying to keep everyone else up there safe, too, which we won’t be able to do if we keep standing here having this stupid heart-to-heart instead of getting shit done. So can you quit the fucking bullshit and just do as I’m saying?”, he reprimanded.

Silence fell between them. Izuku looked baffled; Katsuki continued to glare at him. When the nerd opened and closed his mouth several times without saying anything, Katsuki rolled his eyes and adjusted the two people he was carrying on his shoulders again.

“No, no, you’re right”, Izuku swallowed dry, nodding with a serious expression. Let’s – Let’s go. We can talk about it later”.

Katsuki scoffed, but handed the doorknob anyway.

“Your hearing’s better than mine, so glue your head to the door and listen”, he nodded at the closed door. “If the hall’s clear, we’ll rush out and get to the fucking stairs”.

Izuku leaned forwards and listened attentively for a few moments.

“I don’t hear anything. I think it’s safe for us to go”.

“Fine”, Katsuki huffed, gripping the handle. “I’ll open it, we’ll step out, and we’ll get the hell out of here. You stay behind me”.

“Kacchan –“

“If someone finds us, it’ll be from the front. And I don’t need you to act like my personal shield again, shitty Deku”, he reprimanded.

Izuku looked like he wanted to argue, but he remained silent.

Before he could decide to say anything, Katsuki offered him a short glance and twisted the knob to pull the door open.

That settled it. Izuku stepped out of the deposit before Katsuki had to order him, finally deciding to use his damn head, as it seemed. Katsuki stepped out after him, the two bodies hanging from each of his shoulders slowing his movements a bit and starting to weight down on him.

It was heavy, but Katsuki would have to push through. The real fight hadn’t even started yet. So he walked past Deku, making sure the boy was secure behind him, and took the lead in their escape from the deposit room. He *could* have asked Deku to carry Jirou and help him move faster, but he knew the risk of having the nerd fall and give *her* a concussion was too big.

The hallway was empty, just as Deku had claimed, and they half-walked, half-jogged across it as fast as they could. The bodies Katsuki was carrying jostled against his back with each hurried step he took, which was making them harder to carry, but he couldn’t stop now.

They had just rushed past the closed freight elevator doors when Izuku came to a halt behind Katsuki, reaching out and grabbing the back of his shirt when he didn’t hear him stop.

Katsuki stopped on his tracks, turning around to face Deku. The boy’s eyes were wide with attention and he raised a finger to his closed lips, indicating that Katsuki should be silent. Katsuki didn’t have the time to feel irritated by the gesture.

He tried to hear what Deku was hearing. He squinted from the effort, looking over his shoulder.

Footsteps. Very faint. Just around the corner.

“Fuck”, Katsuki whispered, furious, taking several steps back away from the intersection – away from their escape route – and nodding for Deku to do the same. The footsteps were coming exactly from the direction of the emergency stairs, which meant they wouldn’t be able to reach them without walking right past the very villains they were trying to avoid.

Izuku rushed back towards the deposit, which was the only way they could possibly head to in that dead-end. He opened the door for Katsuki to enter, and once he had walked past the threshold with the two bodies, Izuku followed him in and clicked the door closed silently behind them.

They were once again enveloped in that dim yellow darkness.

“Go back”, Katsuki whispered, nodding at the shelves of the deposit.

“What?”, Izuku whispered as well, exasperated.

“*Back*, back, go to the fucking back”, Katsuki nodded more frantically, urgent, trying to push Deku into the dark corridor of shelves as best as he could while carrying two people on his shoulders.

Deku only hesitated for a second before he obliged, and together they dove deeper towards the far back of the deposit, hoping the shelves and the darkness would be enough to hide them from the arriving villains. It was just avoiding the inevitable, really – as soon as whoever was outside stepped in, they would spot the unconscious, tied up body of the man Katsuki had knocked out, as well as the evident lack of prisoners on the floor.

Hopefully, the villains would assume they had escaped and chase them outside, which was the most logical conclusion, instead of checking the inside of the deposit. That, of course, was ruin Katsuki’s plan of keeping their discretion, since every single villain in the building would start looking for them, but it would still be better than being captured on the spot, barely two minutes into their escape plan.

The front door of the deposit opened just as Katsuki’s and Izuku’s backs contacted with the wall diametrically opposed to it, at the deepest end of the room. From a spot that far back, all the boys could see in the dark were two silhouettes contrasting with the brightness of the hallway, several meters away. Both of them were tall men, but one was broad whereas the other was slim. The first one was carrying another limp body over his shoulder – probably another victim. They were in the middle of a conversation when they stepped into the room.

“ – saying is you can’t keep snatching every single kid that appears in front of you”.

“This one was persistent, I told you. I don’t know how the hell he managed to get out of the auditorium, but he was asking way too many questions. If I’d let him wander back in, he could have spoken to someone”.

“About *what*? He had no proof. Now, his friends will probably come after him, and if too many of them disappear before we start with the plan, we’ll be in fucking trouble –”

“No one will have time to notice this shit. Plus, they won’t be able to step out of the –“

A pause.

Silence. None of the villains said anything for a while.

They had probably noticed there was something wrong, and Katsuki’s blood ran cold.

“What?”, Villain #1 – the broad one – said.

“Lights”, was Villain #2’s short response.

In a second, the lights inside the deposit were turned on with a metallic clang – not the stupid, weak yellow one, but the lamps on the ceiling Katsuki had noticed before, and that were now shining brightly above them. Katsuki and Izuku squinted at the sudden bright light, since

their eyes had grown accustomed to the dark, and they both tried to sink further against the shelves to prevent being seen in the now illuminated room.

“Oh, *shit*”, Villain #1 exclaimed.

Yeah. They’d noticed their victims were gone.

“God *damn* it”, #2 said through gritted teeth.

“Holy shit, man”, #1 said, more frantic. “I fucking *told* you we should have tied the green one tighter”.

“I didn’t think he’d *fucking* – Fuck. *Fuck*! Fuck, ok, drop this – drop this one over there and – I don’t know, alert everyone about it. *Shit*”, Villain #2 said.

Yeah, *shit*. Katsuki couldn’t let him do that, or he’d never even reach the auditorium. He had expected them to *leave* and alert people, not stay in and call someone. If reinforcements arrived, they’d be screwed, because Katsuki would have to fight against god knew how many people at once, while worrying about the safety of his friends and trying to protect them from the backlash. He needed to do something to stop them before they could send word out, he couldn’t let –

“Wait”, Villain #2 said, sharp.

“What?”, Villain #1 asked, clearly nervous.

A pause.

“They’re still here”.

Katsuki froze.

He sensed as Izuku tensed up beside him as well, and he tried to share a look with the boy without making any abrupt movements that could call the villain’s attention, even from afar. Their eyes locked.

“What?”, Villain #1 repeated, and yeah, Katsuki could already tell he was the dumb one.

“The *kids*”, Villain #2 clarified. “They’re still here. I can smell them”.

A pause. Deku reached out and grabbed one of Katsuki’s arms.

“*Don’t* alert anyone”, #2 instructed, emphatic. “We can handle them. God knows I don’t need that asshole calling me incompetent again”.

Katsuki swallowed dry, looking at Deku again.

Silently, slowly, he lowered himself down into a crouch and placed Jirou and the other guy down on the floor as silently as he could.

He would need his hands for this.

"*Kacchan*", Izuku signed at him when he got back to his feet.

It took Katsuki's brain a split second too long to comprehend what the nerd was doing with his hands before he remembered and realized – they didn't need to use their voices and risk being spotted by the villains in order to communicate. As long as they could see each other, they could use sign language.

Katsuki gave Izuku a warning look.

They didn't have many options, here. They were cornered, and Deku's safety was important, but they also had two unconscious people on the floor and hundreds of people possibly stuck with villains upstairs. They needed to work with what they had – Katsuki wasn't in the position of being picky.

Deku was concussed, but he wasn't completely useless. And while Katsuki was worried about the nerd's health, he was also worried they wouldn't make it out of there.

And they *had* to make it out of there.

"*You're strong now?*", Katsuki signed back at Deku.

Izuku swallowed and nodded, only hesitating for a split second.

"*Yes. I'm stronger".*

Katsuki nodded seriously. He hated having to back out on a decision, but he didn't have a choice.

"Carry them", he signed at Izuku with a displeased expression. *"I'll knock the villains out before they can alert anyone. You run out of here while I distract them".*

"But –"

Katsuki held Izuku's hands in his own as a way to prevent him from signing what he knew he would sign – a protest.

A request to stay by his side.

"I'll be right behind you", Katsuki let go of his hands and signed at him. *"I'll see you out of the building. But you'll need to carry them. I won't be able to come back and get them after I'm done with the villains. My plan is to lock them in, so you need to get them out first. Can you do that or what?"*

Izuku looked like he wanted to protest, but he nodded solemnly, serious, aware of their urgency.

"All of the three?", Villain #1 asked, sounding nervous and unaware of their silent conversation.

“No. Four”, Villain #2 said, completely sober.

“*Four*?! The fuck do you mean, four?”, #1 asked, exasperated. “*This* is the fourth one!”, he gestured at the person they had just brought in, and who was lying splayed on the floor, discarded.

“There’s a new one. Other than the quirkless kid”.

Izuku’s eyes widened in perfect synchrony with Katsuki’s. They shared a nervous look.

“Ohh”, #2 said with a humorous, almost amused tone. “That scared them. Yo, close the door”.

Rushed footsteps. The sound of the door clicking closed again.

Fuck.

They’d been so close. If they hadn’t wasted so much time fucking arguing about useless shit, they’d be upstairs by now. Instead, they were stuck, cornered by these shitty D-listers who’d just dragged in yet *another* body for Katsuki to carry. And apparently, the fucker could *smell* them, which was creepy as fuck.

And which also meant a fight was inevitable. Because the villains knew they were there, and there was no way they would manage to escape that one-way-out room without putting sweat on it.

Not that this was a problem to Katsuki. He was dying to finally kick some ass and let some steam out – he would just have to be careful and do so silently.

He stepped in front of Izuku protectively. Maybe the asshat was strong now, strong enough to carry the bodies, but he was still quirkless. And the villains knew that. Katsuki wouldn’t put it past them to take advantage of it.

“You know what? Turn the lights off, too”, #2 instructed, sounding smug. “I don’t need to see them in order to find them, but they won’t be able to do *shit* without seeing *me*”.

Katsuki only had the time to scowl in annoyance before the bright light of the lamps on the ceiling was cut off with another metallic click. To their surprise, the small yellow lamp at the front of the room was also turned off, making the deposit finally emerge into absolute darkness.

Katsuki turned to Deku’s direction, trying to spot him *or* his hands amidst all that black, but it was fruitless – his eyes had now grown accustomed to the bright light, and now all that met his sight was the void.

Great. Now they wouldn’t even be able to communicate using sign language.

Katsuki stayed where he was, standing in front of Deku protectively, but he reached out behind him with his hand, trying to grab something of Deku’s. His fingertips found the front

of Deku's shirt and he gripped it, feeling as one of Deku's hands clutched to his wrist in return. At least this way they knew where the other was, even if they couldn't see.

All they could do was stand there and wait to be found, wait until one of the villains got close enough so Katsuki could knock them out without using his explosions – or at least using an explosion that was small enough not to call attention.

Together, they heard as the slow-paced footsteps of Villain #2 got increasingly closer. Except hearing wasn't exactly Katsuki's top ability right now, so he squinted at the dark in anticipation, heart racing, ready to get his hands to start popping if it came down to it.

"You know, *heroes*", Villain #2 teased from somewhere to their right, which was unsettling, because Katsuki could have sworn he had been coming from the left. His steps were so slow they became annoying, as if he was going out of his way to show the two of them just how little their chance at escape was – so little he didn't even have to hurry. "There's no way out of this room other than that door. And I can tell two of you are unconscious, one of you is injured and quirkless, and one of you is dead *scared*".

Katsuki growled in rage, louder than he had intended to. Deku's grip on his wrist tightened, a silent warning.

"Oh, come on. You know I'm right", #2 chuckled. "You're these people's only chance at escape, and they're all useless to help you. And you don't even know what my quirk is".

Katsuki took a step back to shield Deku further, making sure he, Jirou, and whoever the hell that other guy was were safely trapped between himself and the wall behind them.

"Why don't I spare you the trouble, huh?", #2 continued. His voice was getting closer and closer, but still fucking *slow* – and Katsuki absolutely hated it. He could feel the hatred boiling harder inside him with each of the villain's leisure steps. "I bet you're *dying* to find out how I know your friend is quirkless, or how I know that two of you are unconscious, or how I know you're *Bakugou Katsuki*, that feral boy from UA who has the explosion quirk and who won the Sports Festival a while back".

Katsuki's heart was racing inside his chest, but his expression remained the same, even if no one could see it in the dark – angry, and serious, and ready. Determined. Focused.

Focus. *Focus*.

"My quirk is really simple, if you think about it", #2 continued.

He sounded closer to them, now, but Katsuki needed to wait. He couldn't risk jumping into an attack and missing, because that would mess up their escape and they couldn't afford mess ups. He couldn't rush into things like he did last time, he needed to wait, just a bit more…

"I can smell other quirks. And I can tell what they are. Depending on how close I am to a person, the image becomes clearer in my mind's eye".

Step, step, step, echoing across the long corridors. He was getting closer to them.

“I know the girl has a sound quirk. I know the boy has a size quirk. I know the other boy has no quirk. And you –“, he snorted. “Have the stench of nitroglycerin and *smoke* all over you”.

A pause. Katsuki’s senses were toned up to a thousand as a way to compensate for his impaired hearing, and he tried to figure out where the guy was coming from, and where the hell was the other –

Wait. Where the hell was the other one?

“And I know exactly what you’ll try to do to escape”, #2 chuckled. “You see, just being able to track quirks isn’t always enough, right? What’s the use of seeing people if I don’t *know* them? Since I was going to be a hero, I did my homework. I studied. And now I know everything there is to know about *everyone* who has the slightest bit of importance to the hero industry. Because it *is* an industry, right? I mean, look at all the *merch* and the *ads* and the – and the literal *propaganda* going around. And you, Bakugou-kun, are just another pawn in this great game of chess that our society has become. Yet another little disposable hero wannabe that will die to serve the king’s greater purpose, without even knowing why. And you can tell yourself that you’re important all you want – it doesn’t change the fact that, in the face of everything else, you’re basically *meaningless*”.

Deku tightened his grip on Katsuki’s wrist when Katsuki let go of the front of his shirt. Tension was growing.

“*Kacchan* –“, Izuku whispered, his voice so low Katsuki barely managed to hear it.

“I *also* know everything about you and your *Howitzer Impacto*”, the villain continued mockingly. Katsuki was starting to realize the villain sounded young – maybe a couple years older than him. It had been impossible to tell in the dark and from the distance, but… He really *did* sound like a student.

What the fuck?

“You know, the police tried to cover it up and they did an excellent job at that, but I still couldn’t help but to notice there was a recent accident in a sewer gallery near UA… When was it, last year…?”, he hummed pensively. “And the aftereffects were very similar to an… extremely potent *explosion*”.

Ok. Katsuki counted his breaths. Usually, he’d take deep, calm breaths in a situation like this, but they would be useless to him, now. Instead, he took short breaths, small breaths, breaths that barely even ventilated his brain, all the while shaking his hands and bouncing one of his legs in anticipation. Deku didn’t let go of his forearm.

“Your quirk doesn’t fare well in small, closed environments like this one”, #2 concluded. “So, whatever you’re planning, give it up. This building’s construction was rushed by the Estate so that the museum could open on schedule. It doesn’t have a really *strong* foundation. If you attack us right now, you’ll bring the entire structure down, along with your friends and everyone else who’s upstairs. And that’s not very heroic, is it? Not that *you* are very heroic, after all…”, he mocked again, giggling. “But you did resist the League, so I think it’s safe to assume you’re not willing to murder hundreds of innocent people in cold blood”.

Katsuki scowled and growled again. Deku's grip on his wrist became even tighter.

Then it dawned on him. Deku wasn't scared and seeking for comfort. He was holding him back.

Telling him to wait.

Because he knew Katsuki was amazing at many things, but resisting to taunting was *not* one of them.

"So, why don't you turn yourself in and spare everyone else the trouble, huh?", Villain #2 concluded. "Before anyone gets hurt".

Katsuki fumed. This guy had fucking kidnapped his friends and now he was threatening everyone at the event *and* telling Katsuki to turn himself in? As if.

As fucking *if*.

"You know, we're not going to kill anyone", #2 continued. "That was never our intention. Actually, I should take this opportunity to apologize for the ropes and the tape. It was a bit extreme, but we needed to ensure no one would try to get in the way. I'm sure you'll understand once we are done up there".

He remained silent, as was Deku behind him. Breathing shallowly. Bouncing his legs and his arms frantically, restlessly. Waiting. Waiting for the chance –

"And I already know where you are", the villain said as if reading his thoughts – as if *smelling* his anticipation. "I'm just waiting for you to be reasonable and make the sensible choice. Come on, Bakugou-kun. Come out", he added in a sing-song voice. Like Katsuki was some sort of *dog*.

"Kacchan", Izuku whispered again behind him, so close to his ear Katsuki felt his hot breath on his skin, sending shivers down his spine.

"Wait", Katsuki whispered back, facing forward instead of trying to find Deku's eyes in the dark. Whether the advice was fully intended to Deku or to himself, he didn't know.

"But –"

"*Wait*", he yanked his arm away from Deku's grasp as emphasis.

"I can smell it, you know", the villain scoffed, and Katsuki wanted nothing more than to kick his teeth in. "The more fear you feel, the clearer you become to me. And you're very clear right now".

"I have an idea", Izuku whispered again. Katsuki gritted his teeth, struggling to keep his cool. Deku was about to ruin his plan.

"Deku. *Not. Now"*.

“Just –“, he hesitated, sighing.

A beat. He touched Katsuki’s arm gently, rubbing his thumb on his forearm, before letting go again.

“You’ll have to trust me”.

And then, before Katsuki could do anything, Izuku squeezed past him and disappeared.

Katsuki reached out and almost, *almost* managed to grab a hold of his shirt and hold him back, but missed by a split millimeter. He had fucking missed. Again.

Deku was gone, and Katsuki couldn’t see or hear where he went.

All alone and concussed. In the dark. With two villains around, ready to grab them.

Fuck. Shit.

Fuck.

Fucking shit.

“Ohh”, Villain #2 teased, back to sounding amused. “The fear is becoming more intense, isn’t it?”

The rhythm of Katsuki’s breathing sped up, but he remained where he was, glued to his feet, highly aware of Ears and the other guy on the floor behind him. There was no point going after Deku – it was too dark, he wouldn’t be able to see him, and there was a chance he wouldn’t be able to hear him, either. If anything, chasing after Deku would end up putting them in *more* trouble.

But he couldn’t leave Deku all alone.

Ok, think. Strategize. One of his senses were already impaired; now, he had temporarily lost access to his sight. Meanwhile, the guy he was facing off against had an extremely heightened sense of smell that apparently made up for his current blindness. Which meant Katsuki was in disadvantage.

(Not that this had ever stopped him before.)

“It’s ok. I understand. I really do”, Villain #2 said after a few moments. Katsuki tightened his hands into fists. “You know, I wanted to be a hero, like you. But then I saw the truth. We all saw the truth. And actually… We have you to thank you for that”.

Katsuki frowned.

“If you hadn’t caused All Might’s demise… We wouldn’t have seen it”, he added.

Katsuki blinked. The world around him stopped.

What…?

“Nothing to say for yourself?”, the villain reprimanded. “You won’t be so silent when you see it, trust me. When you see how All Might *ruined* everything, and how he deserves to be buried and forgotten and *obliterated* from History. That’s the only way our society will find *real* peace. The peace that he’s advocated and defended for so many years, and that he only pushed away from us”.

Katsuki frowned again. Fine, the guy was obviously fucking mental. He had kidnapped a bunch of people, of *course* he’d be part of a creepy anti-All Might club. But was this the League again? It didn’t sound like it. It didn’t *seem* like it, either. He hadn’t seen anyone he recognized and this guy’s voice was completely foreign to him. It also didn’t seem their style – a flashy invasion would be more like them than this stealthy infiltration.

“I used to be All Might’s number one fan, you know”, the man continued. “Until I saw the truth. Until I saw the damage he brought, the cancer he is to a society like ours. And now – all I want to do – all *we* want to do – is show the rest of the world what we saw. And set it free”.

Katsuki stayed where he was, waiting. Even though the guy had claimed to know where he was, his voice was still getting closer and closer, as were his footsteps. He was still approaching him, and he had also been right – Katsuki’s big attacks didn’t work well in closed environments, as his current impaired hearing reminded him. So even if he was desperately eager to howitzer-impacto this guy into another continent, he wouldn’t be able to do that – *and* the noise would call too much attention.

He needed to wait until the guy was close enough to him, so that he could either take him down on hand-to-hand combat, or so that he could use small, controlled explosions to blow his face off and be done with it. And he couldn’t stop thinking about where Deku was, and what he was doing, and why the fuck he would just *leave* like that when Katsuki was so close to finding a way out, to capturing this guy –

“We want everyone to see how the ‘Symbol of Peace’ was nothing but a warmonger in its core, nothing but a motivator for villains. Greatness generates challenge. Challenge generates conflict. Conflicts generates war – and death, and everything that comes with it. The only way our society will be great again is if we –“

A sharp, metallic thud interrupted the villain’s speech, followed by the sound of a body collapsing with the floor.

A pause.

“*I’m* All Might’s number one fan, you idiot”, Deku’s voice resonated from the darkness.

Katsuki stared blankly at the darkness in front of him, and then he couldn’t help but to smirk.

This damn nerd.

Then, everything happened at once.

“Kacchan!”, Deku shouted, urgent, his echoing, booming voice contrasting with his cautious whisper from mere moments before. “Go!”

He didn’t have to say it twice.

Pop, pop, pop. Tiny explosions erupted on Katsuki’s palms, creating a source of light strong enough to illuminate his immediate surroundings. Katsuki turned his head just in time to see Villain #1, who had been missing from action, jumping at him from the distance, probably deciding to finally do something now that their Plan A had clearly gone to shit. They clearly hadn’t expected the quirkless kid to take the sniffer out.

Think fast, think hard, strategize. Villain #2 tracked quirks. Now that Katsuki had gotten a good, albeit quick look at Villain #1, he could tell he was clearly the one who had posed as the sound tech guy and led Jirou away from the auditorium. Which meant there was a high chance he was also the one who drugged people with skin-to-skin contact, especially because he had been the one carrying the new body when they entered the room.

you can’t keep snatching every single kid that appears in front of you –

And if he *was* the drugger, he and #2 would be a great fucking duo – one did the tracking, the other did the drugging. Easiest way to capture people who could get in the way. In a scenario where Katsuki couldn’t attest that theory without rendering himself fucking unconscious in the process, the safest course of action would be to *presume* he was right and that this asshole was the one who could knock people out with one simple touch.

Ergo, don’t let him touch his skin.

Katsuki dodged just in time to miss #1’s hand reaching for his face. He took the chance to hit a punch packed with a mild explosion to the man’s right flank, throwing him off balance and sending him flying across the corridor of shelves. The explosion barely emitted anything louder than a dry pop – Katsuki doubted someone outside the room even heard it.

The villain collided heavily against a shelf, but didn’t pass out – and, just as Deku managed to run back to the front of the deposit and turn all the lights back on, the man was back on his feet, launching himself at Katsuki again with a loud growl.

Katsuki squinted at the sudden brightness – would this fucking cycle of light-dark-light-dark *stop* already?! –, but managed to dodge yet another hand reaching for him. Through his peripheral vision, he spotted Deku rushing past them once again and grabbing Jirou and the other guy like Katsuki had asked him to, dragging them away from the fight and towards the door with only a bit of difficulty.

“Stay – *still*!”, the villain grunted with annoyance when Katsuki dodged yet another one of his hands trying to grab him.

“*You* stay still, asshole”, Katsuki barked, snarling. “Don’t enter a fight that you can’t win and then beg for you opponent to lose!”

#1 grunted loudly, plunging at Katsuki. This time, his fingertips managed to brush the boy's right thigh, but the skin was covered by his pants and thus the quirk had no effect. Katsuki, in response, aimed another small explosion at the man's hand before he managed to grab much else.

#1 screamed in pain at the heat, and Katsuki took the distraction to emit two small explosions that were just enough to propel himself off the ground. Midair, he emitted another small explosion to change his course, and then he reached what he had been aiming for – the top of the heavy, metal shelf, which was full of equally heavy equipment.

Katsuki squatted down at the top of the shelf, grabbing its metallic hem and turning his head to look at the villain. He almost looked like a gargoyle like that.

"Nice fight, jackass", Katsuki said with a vicious grin on his face. "But actually, it was lousy, so fuck you and your creepy anti-All Might cult".

Saying that, he propelled himself forwards with two more explosions. With the impulse, he kicked the shelf back.

The heavy shelf groaned, toppled, and collapsed on the top of #1 before he could roll away or move. The weight quickly pinned his struggling, grunting form down, and Katsuki landed graciously in front of him, palms fuming and face rageful.

It was his turn to walk leisurely towards the fallen villain, taking his time and rejoicing just a bit in his victory before he crouched down in front of him. The villain was struggling and trying to wriggle himself free from the heavy shelf, but it was to no avail – the weight was too grand.

Katsuki reached out past the metallic shelf and grabbed the walkie-talkie that was attached to Villain #1's belt – the one he was supposed to use as a way to communicate with his associates. He inspected the device for a second before averting his eyes back to the man.

"Do me a favor", Katsuki said, stern, but with a hint of scornfulness in his tone. He leaned in closer to the villain, a glare on his victorious face. "When your pathetic, ignorant friend wakes up, tell him that part of my explosion quirk is to secrete nitroglycerin. I've been training all my life to master it, and I've reached a point where I can basically *sweat on command* most of the time. That means it wasn't my *fear* he was smelling with his shitty quirk".

He raised the hand that was holding the walkie-talkie and crashed the device into his palm with a small, controlled explosion, reducing it to fuming wreckage. The brief light it emitted was enough to put his grinning, victorious face on orange display to the villain, who had the decency to look terrified at the sight.

Katsuki dropped the smoking remains of the walkie-talkie beside #1's head with disdain.

"He was smelling my *rage*".

Then, he took the villain out with a single punch.

Chapter End Notes

Posting this chapter was giving me SO much anxiety, because it feels... I don't know. Inconclusive? Repetitive? I don't know. But it also felt wrong to keep going and leave the next part in this chapter, so I HAD to split it... I just hope it turned out well djaskldsa

Anyway. They're both so dumb they can't help but jump at each other's throat at any given opportunity. Really, Midoriya? You wanna talk about your unresolved feelings after months of silence in the middle of a villain attack? While best girl Jirou is passed out on the floor? What is this, a sordid romcom?

I feel like this chapter is long as fuck for the amount of in-story time it covers. I'd like to say that everything that happened - from Katsuki pinning Deku down to the floor to him knocking the villain out - happened in... idk. Ten minutes? More or less? It was all pretty quick, it's just the ~introspection~ that makes it seem longer. Also, I like to think Katsuki's a thinker/analyzer just like Deku, he just doesn't verbalize it. I did try to show it through this chapter (and... through the past ones, also), which probably ended up dragging out/stalling the action scenes a bit. I did think the introspection was important to leave in, so... Idk, man. I'm trying my best over here.

I currently have the flu and I've been feeling like shit because of ~anxiety~ this past few weeks, so any hate WILL make me cry like a baby. I'm still open to constructive criticism tho, so leave a comment if anything bothers you/if you have any suggestions!

As usual, thank you so much for reading, commenting and kudo-ing! And I'll see you all on the infamous ~next chapter~... which is where the thing everyone's been waiting for happens.

(...unless it gets too big and I decide to split it up again. I'M SORRY OK)

Chapter 24: Save To Win

Chapter Notes

> Some people talked about cliffhangers on the comments of the last chapter, so heads up: this chapter ends in a cliffhanger. If you don't feel comfortable with this, please, wait until the next chapter is up before you read this one ^_^ Stay safe, guys!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Katsuki marched towards Deku, who was struggling to drag an unconscious Jirou, Whoever-This-Guy-Is, and apparently *Kaminari* towards the door at the same time. Somewhere beside him, the crowbar Deku had used to attack Katsuki laid discarded on the floor, the nerd's hands too busy to carry it along.

"What the fuck?", Katsuki frowned as he got closer, jogging towards them as soon as he spotted the limp Kaminari hanging from one of Deku's arms. "What is Dunce Face doing here?"

"I don't know", Izuku panted, allowing Katsuki to reach out and take Kaminari from him before bending forwards to catch his breath.

He *was* stronger, that was a fact – but still not strong enough to carry three bodies around on his own. He gently set Jirou and the other guy down as he panted, but made sure they were held in a tight grip and propped up against his legs, lest they fall to the floor.

"He was the one they brought in when they arrived", Izuku gasped, nodding at Kaminari, who was now hanging limply from Katsuki's hold, one arm thrown around the explosive boy's shoulders as Katsuki held him in an upright position. "Maybe he came out to look for you and Jirou-san?"

Yeah, that was about the only possible explanation. That, or Dunce Face had managed to sneak out to do something as ridiculous as to go to the bathroom in the middle of a hijack and got himself caught like the idiot he was. That was also a possibility.

"Tch. What a fucking *idiot*", Katsuki scoffed with the subtlest hint of concern in his voice, sparing the unconscious Kaminari a side glance and trying not to dwell on the way the idiot's head had lolled on his shoulder, tucking itself against his neck. Katsuki didn't really want to carry Kaminari around, since he could predict the amount of teasing that would result on once the boy was conscious again, but they didn't really have much of a choice.

He seemed more stir-y than Jirou had been when he first got to her; Katsuki could feel the way he was twitching slightly in his slumber and how his eyes were moving rapidly beneath his closed lids. Still, Kaminari was giving no signs he was about to wake up anytime soon,

still hanging from Katsuki, whose hands were holding his arm and his waist as he leaned heavily against him.

The villains hadn't had the chance or the time to tie Kaminari up and gag him like they had done to the others, since, as soon as they stepped into the deposit room, they had noticed their other victims were gone. Also, Kaminari didn't display any signs of violence – no gashes on his forehead or any bruises Katsuki could see.

Which meant he had been drugged by the villain. Like Ears and the other guy.

Which also meant Deku had been the *only* unlucky bastard to get caught by the wrong villain and have the shit knocked out of him. Because it had to be him, right?

Also also, it *had* to be fucking Kaminari to come looking for them, for fuck's sake. And now, he and Deku had yet another body to carry around during their escape.

How fucking great.

"We need to get the fuck out of here", Katsuki said once he assessed Kaminari was as fine as he could be on that moment. "We can't know for sure that they didn't warn someone else while we were playing cat and mouse in the dark, and I don't want to stay and find out".

"*Hai*", Deku nodded compliantly.

Katsuki adjusted Kaminari in his grip and threw his unconscious body over his shoulder like a sack of potatoes. This way, at least one of his hands was free, in case he needed to use it.

"Gimme those two", Katsuki nodded at Jirou and Whatshisname, who Deku had thrown over his shoulders, just like Katsuki did with Kaminari.

He was well aware of the fact that, barely five minutes ago, he and Deku had almost thrown hands with each other over that same issue, since Katsuki wouldn't let him carry either of the bodies. It was almost comical to notice the contrast now – Deku carrying *two* bodies, while Katsuki only carried one. Because there always had to be a worse option, right?

As much as he hated to admit it, Deku had a point – and Katsuki needed his mobility to be as optimal as possible in a situation like this, which wouldn't exactly be achievable if he was busy carrying more than one unconscious person.

But Deku's knees seemed wobbly. Katsuki noticed how his whole frame was trembling as he put up an immense effort to carry two people without swaying on his feet at the same time. And to think the shitty nerd had been capable of lifting ridiculous amounts of weight barely a year before – possibly hitting triple digits, he wouldn't doubt it.

"No, I'm – I'm good", Izuku swallowed dry, his voice sounding tight. Katsuki could tell his breathing was labored, probably from the strain he was under, and he honestly fucking hated that Deku was under such stress *and* having to put up with so much effort while he was still recovering. Even if he looked stronger.

Katsuki sighed, a twist of guilt – which he decided to interpret as annoyance, because that would be easier to deal with on that moment – erupting in his stomach.

“Forget about the fucking ego thing”, he spat. “You sound like you’re about to keel over. Hand the guy over to me and carry Ears only –“

“Kacchan”, Deku interrupted, serious, albeit with effort. His teeth were gritted. “I’m good. I can do this. Let’s just go already”.

Katsuki huffed and clicked his tongue.

“You’re a fucking idiot”, he complained.

“An idiot who just saved your life”, Deku retorted.

“You hardly *saved my life*, shitty Deku”.

“Oh, yeah? What would you call ‘knocking out the villain who was about to attack you in the dark’, then?”, Deku said, uncharacteristically snappy. Maybe it was the fucking concussion taking its toll on him, or the effort making him stressed. His speech wasn’t as slurred as it had been when he first woke up, but he was still… Lagging. Like his brain was slower. And clearly more irritable.

Katsuki sighed.

“Helping me out”.

“*Helping you out*?”, Deku scoffed in amusement.

“Yeah. Giving me a fucking hand, or whatever. But you didn’t save me. And I don’t fucking need you to”.

“Yeah, ok, Kacchan”.

A pause. Katsuki glared at Izuku in the dark.

This talk was heading towards a path that neither of them wanted to thread in. Not at that moment of crisis, at least. A flash of memory of a tiny, childish hand reaching out for him as he sat in a river erupted in his memory, and Katsuki shook his head before his feelings could erupt along with that.

He had more pressing matters at hand. He needed to focus on what mattered. If Deku wanted to carry the fucking bodies, then fine. It would be better to have him act as a mule than to have him sacrifice himself if they met another villain because Katsuki was too busy with the weight to protect him.

“Did you knock him out with the crowbar?”, Katsuki nodded at their backs, at the end of the deposit, in an attempt to change the subject.

“Well”, Izuku said, not looking at him but apparently realizing that it would be for the best not to dwell on that argument. “He said he could see you more clearly the closer he got to you. And he talked about your fear, and your quirk, and… And Jirou-san’s, and… And I – W-Well. He never talked about me”.

Katsuki stared at him for a split moment.

“Because you don’t have a quirk right now”.

Izuku continued to avoid his eyes, but nodded briefly.

“Yeah. So I figured he wouldn’t be able to see me, or – *sniff* me, or however his quirk works. I think that was how he figured out I was…”

Silence.

None of them needed to say the word.

“So I just sneaked up to him really silently and knocked him out with the crowbar. I had to go all the way back to the front to grab it, though, and I had to be careful not to run into the other villain. That’s why it took me a while. I couldn’t really see anything properly with all the lights out”.

Katsuki scoffed in amusement. The quick thinking was impressive, not that he would admit it aloud. He hadn’t even considered the possibility that the villain wouldn’t be able to see Deku coming when they had been cornered, too focused on how to blow the guy’s face off while making as little noise as possible and not fucking up his future hero career. To know that Deku had had an idea that *he* hadn’t in a moment of danger pissed him off, especially because the nerd seemed distracted in comparison to him.

He should be the one in charge. He should be the one having the ideas and keeping Deku safe, and not the other way around. He needed to do a better job.

He studied Deku’s face, noticing how he was still avoiding his eyes.

Slowly, he crouched on the floor and set Kaminari back down. Deku offered him a confused look, still holding Jirou and Whatshisname up.

“I dropped the shelf on the drugger asshole”, Katsuki said calmly. “But you just knocked the other fucker down, right? With the crowbar?”

Izuku nodded seriously. He looked pale.

“So, if we leave him like that, he could wake up and call for back up. That’d ruin the stealthy aspect of our escape plan”.

Izuku squinted in confusion at him for a few moments before his face fell in comprehension. He closed his eyes for a brief moment and sighed.

“Ah, crap”.

“You kiss your mother with that mouth, Deku?”

Izuku rolled his eyes.

“You’re one to speak”.

“Put them down”, Katsuki instructed, nodding at Jirou and the other guy at the same time he got back to his feet. “Let’s go back and tie that tracking douchebag up”.

“Shouldn’t we…”, Izuku hesitated, frowning. “I mean, shouldn’t we just… uh, get… going already?”

Katsuki narrowed his eyes at him.

“I’m not going through the effort of getting my ass back upstairs just to get caught in the last minute because I was too lazy to tie one knocked-out villain up and he ended up calling for backup”, Katsuki barked over his shoulder, already marching back towards the shelves and looking for the one with the ropes and duct tape. “And it’s not like we haven’t wasted a fuckton of time already. This will take us two minutes”.

“Right”, Izuku said after a few moments. “Right. You’re right”, he lowered himself down, placing Jirou and Whatshisname on the floor carefully. He let out a muffled hiss as he did so, making Katsuki send him an inspecting look over his shoulder.

Izuku got back to his feet and rushed towards him, putting an especial effort into looking ok. The dried blood on his pale face and the X-shaped duct tape covering his gruesome injury from view didn’t really help his endeavor, but at least he was no longer swaying.

“You ok?”, Katsuki, ropes and tape already in hands, narrowed his eyes at Deku as he approached him.

“Yeah, I’m good”, Izuku said, not meeting his eyes.

“Deku”, Katsuki said simply, dryly. Izuku met his gaze.

Dilated pupils. One seemingly larger than the other, which was definitely no good sign. But his eyes didn’t seem to be as glassy as before. He seemed more sober. He was no longer slurring so much.

Maybe it was the adrenaline of the fight. Maybe the concussion wasn’t so bad, maybe Katsuki’s brain was playing tricks on him. How could he even tell anymore? He could no longer be sure of when he was just being paranoid and when he was actually right to freak out.

But he knew he couldn’t risk it.

“What?”, Izuku asked when Katsuki did nothing other than stare at him, not saying anything.

“Nothing”, Katsuki scoffed. “Just making sure you’re not about to faint on me like a loser”.

Izuku sighed, but followed Katsuki silently as the boy marched further into the deposit, looking for the Quirk Sniffer.

“I won’t faint, Kacchan”, Izuku said tiredly.

“You better not”, Katsuki warned simply, his back turned to Izuku, confident that he was doing a good job at hiding the concern from his tone. “I ain’t carrying *four* bodies around”.

“Why, is it too hard?”, Izuku dared to say, the hint of provocation in his tone.

There was the fucking snappiness again. The head injury had clearly made him lose his mind if he was feeling lucky to the point of downright *mocking* Katsuki.

Katsuki’s hands tightened into a grip around the ropes and tape he was holding.

“*Try* me, you bastard. I’ll carry you four losers *and* the villains if it comes to it”.

“That will only slow you down”, Izuku merely huffed out as he walked alongside him.

That was definitely not the reaction Katsuki had expected to urge out of him – he had been hoping for a muffled chuckle, maybe –, but he decided to leave it at that (*just this once*), because at that exact same time he finally spotted the unconscious body of the villain.

He rushed towards the guy and knelt down beside him with a scornful look on his face. Deku caught up with him and knelt down as well.

The man was out cold, head lolled to the side to reveal a sharp cut across his hairline. After inspecting him for a moment to make sure he was actually out of commission, Katsuki handed Izuku a piece of rope. He worked on tying the villain’s hands while Izuku did the same to his legs.

“That looks precise”, Katsuki commented, not looking at Deku and focusing on the ropes. Deku spared the cut on the villain’s head a quick glance before shrugging.

“Wish I could take the credit. It was so dark, I was lucky to get his head right”, Izuku said, not looking at him either.

“Tch”, was Katsuki’s only response.

A few seconds of silent knot-tying passed.

Once they were done, Katsuki grabbed Quirk Sniffer’s walkie and destroyed it, just like he had done to the other villain’s. Deku pulled against the knots he had just tied and forced them to make sure they wouldn’t give way, and once he was satisfied with the result, they stood up almost simultaneously.

“Shouldn’t we tie the other villain up as well?”, Izuku suggested, cautious. “I mean… Just to be safe, since we’re here already”.

Katsuki's desire was to yell something in the lines of *what, you think so little of me that you're assuming that fucking extra is going to wake up anytime soon after I blew his face up?*, but something about the expression on Deku's face stopped him from doing that. Not that *Deku* or his shitty face had the power to stop Katsuki from doing anything; he just didn't want to waste any more time with useless arguments that slowed them down.

And Deku's suggestion actually made a bit of sense, if he had to be honest.

So instead of protesting, he merely clicked his tongue and barked out a sharp "Yeah", before grabbing the ropes that were left and making his way back to the other villain.

Deku followed him as usual.

Then, midway to the corridor where the Drugger Villain was buried beneath a shelf, a loud static-like noise made Katsuki and Izuku jump.

Katsuki would never admit it out loud, but that shit was so sudden it nearly made his heart stop. He automatically jumped in front of Deku to shield him from the unknown incoming danger before he realized the noise was coming from the walkie-talkie he had stolen from the first villain that arrived at the deposit room.

He let go of his firm grip on Deku's arm with a sigh and grabbed the walkie, ignoring how Deku's eyes seemed to be bulging out of his skull in equal fear and surprise. Katsuki could have sworn he had turned the damn thing off when he took it, but again – his brain was so messed up lately that he couldn't be sure. He pressed the off button and placed the thing back on his belt.

"Fucking villains", he muttered under his breath, sparing Deku a quick glance before they resumed walking.

Once they got to the villain, Katsuki went ahead and began the process of lifting the heavy shelf off him with a groan, so that they could tie the guy up properly. The shelf was heavy as fuck, but Drugger was well-built and he looked strong. Now that he put some thought into it, Katsuki would rather tie him up properly and be done with it than to assume the weight of the shelf would be enough to keep him trapped and risk having the asshole escape before they got to the 11th floor.

Izuku looked like he wanted to help Katsuki with the weight but, apparently finding some common sense for once, he crouched down instead and started to tie the villain up to gain them some time. They needed to get out of there as soon as possible, and there was no point in trying to help Katsuki with something he could clearly handle on his own.

(If anything, he'd probably be offended by Deku's attempt to help).

Deku worked on the unconscious villain while Katsuki pushed the fallen shelf away, and by the time Katsuki was done with the heavy weight, allowing the shelf to collide with the floor with a dull thud, Izuku had already resumed restraining the Drugger Villain.

Katsuki approached him again, a serious look on his face.

“I don’t think it’s a long stretch to say these two assholes weren’t the villain’s top-notch front of attack”, he commented, rubbing his hands to get rid of the dust on them and looking around the dark deposit with a somber expression. “They were probably just two disposable henchmen who happened to work well together. One tracked down the people who could get in the way, the other knocked them out without calling too much attention. Which means th–“

“They were just path clearers”, Izuku provided from where he was still crouching on the floor.

Katsuki gritted his teeth.

“Yeah”, he forced himself to nod, not willing to allow himself to be pissed at Deku’s interruption. He had bigger problems to focus on at that time. “Their actual forces”, he pointed at the ceiling, “are probably up there”.

“At the auditorium”, Izuku provided again, getting back to his feet. He was looking into Katsuki’s eyes, now, but there was something wrong about his gaze. Katsuki couldn’t really pinpoint what was bothering him, though.

“Yeah”, he nodded again, facing away from Deku with an angry scowl. *Get it together.* “And like you said, they’re probably looking for me. The chance these assholes told them about us is small, since the idiot over there didn’t want to seem like a loser to his boss, but there’s no way the security guy didn’t notice I never came back from the bathroom. We can’t be sure”, he shook his head, placing both hands on his hips.

A pause. Deku kept looking at him, waiting for him to continue. Katsuki clicked his tongue.

“This deposit isn’t being swarmed by villains, though, so we gotta take what we can get and carry on with the plan of heading back upstairs”, he continued. “But I’m not gonna count on us being lucky, and I want to work with actual numbers here. So here’s what we’re gonna do”, he pointed at Deku, authority written all over his tone. “We’re gonna head to the exit stairs, like we were doing before those assholes arrived”.

“*Hai*”, Deku nodded.

“We’ll try not to make too much noise or call too much attention. If the villains are looking for me, they’ll probably search from the top to the bottom of the building, since that’s where I was last seen. We should be able to make it to the stairs without being spotted. If we *are* spotted – we’ll fight our way up. Using our fucking heads, not our quirks”.

“*Hai*”.

“And once we get to the first floor, we’ll get you out of the building through a window. I’ll cover your back, because it actually makes sense that there will be some asshole villain with a lower quirk standing sentinel or some shit like you said. These fuckers seem to be pretty organized. Once you get out of the jammed signal range, you call someone. All Might, Aizawa sensei, the police, the three of them, I don’t give a shit. Just let someone know what’s happening, and *get the hell out of here*. After I cover for you, I’ll come back and stall these assholes before they can do whatever it is they’re planning to do”.

Izuku stared at him. No "*hai*" this time.

Katsuki knew what that meant and he sighed.

"*Deku* –"

"I don't want to leave you behind", Deku blurted out before he could continue, serious and determined.

Katsuki rolled his eyes, becoming impatient. This shit again? Couldn't they just *stop* walking around in circles?!

"You won't be *leaving me*", he pointed out, annoyed. "We *just went through this*, shitty Deku. You'll be helping me rescue everyone. Isn't that what you want? To fucking save people?"

"Yes", Deku said without hesitation, serious. "But I don't want to do that by running away".

Katsuki sighed heavily.

"Deku", he said, serious. "You won't be running away".

"I will", Deku protested, and fuck, why did his voice become so wobbly out of a sudden? And when did his eyes become so shiny? "I will, because you'll stay back here and you'll be in danger. All our friends will be in danger, and you'll be in the hands of these villains while I find my way to safety. And I'm not that kind of person, Kacchan, I don't – I don't run away to find help, I don't mind my own business when there are people in danger. I jump in and I do what I can, like I did with the Sludge Villain, and like I tried to do back at the Training Camp. Like I just did right *now*, when I knocked that villain out with the crowbar. I can help you. What I *can't* do is –", he shook his head. "Is leave you. I never could, not even back then. The worst thing I've ever gone through was watching you being taken by those villains and not being able to do anything to stop it".

Katsuki stared at him.

"That's not the worst thing you've ever gone through", he pointed out, confused.

Because really? A month as a ghost and fucking having his heart stop on a medical table and *this* was Deku's top worst moment?

Izuku sighed, closing his eyes for a brief second before reopening them.

"Kacchan –"

"*Deku*", he interrupted him, irritation and anger evident in his voice. "I thought we had agreed to discuss this shit later. You're the only one who can take them to safety right now. We can't just leave them here and risk some other villain get them or use them as leverage. You're the only one who can call for help".

Deku looked determined.

“So why don’t you with me and bring them along?”, he asked, the words coming out like a riddle. Like some sort of test.

“You know I can’t”, Katsuki scoffed. “There are people upstairs”.

“I know”, Deku said, nodding emphatically as if that was the point he was trying to make. “That’s why I can’t go, either. That’s what I’m trying to make you see. The reason you can’t go with me is the same reason I can’t go on my own”.

“What?”

Deku shook his head.

“If I run away and leave you and all our friends behind, then I won’t be able to call myself a hero”.

Katsuki scoffed, more irritated. What, was that cheesy line supposed to melt his heart and convince him? He took a step closer to Deku, anger radiating from him.

“Again, since you’re apparently incapable of getting this shit into that concussed brain of yours – you won’t be *running away*. You’ll be part of the fucking *rescue*”, he spat. “What do you want me to do, Deku? Let *you* go upstairs and confront the villains instead while I go out with the three the losers and ring All Might? You know I can’t let you fucking do it. And you know damn well why, so don’t make me say it for the millionth fucking time. And if *you* don’t do it, then no one will ring the cops and we’ll go upstairs for nothing, because we don’t actually have permission to engage in quirk-using combat with those dickheads up there without the supervision of a pro, we can’t defeat a bunch of them only on hand-to-hand, and we’ll probably just end up being captured with the rest of the losers. Is that what you want?”

Izuku looked away, seeming angry and upset and –

Still determined.

Katsuki had no more arguments, nothing he could say to change Deku’s mind. It was like talking to a damn wall. He felt like they were having the same discussion over and over and over again, every time they tried to speak to each other. And it was fucking *tiring.*

He could deliver a little speech on how Deku had taught him that a hero is more than a quirk, he could try to reason with him and argue and order him around. He could start another fight, he could bring hell on earth and he knew, deep down, that none of it would change Deku’s stubborn mind. Calling him quirkless all those months ago had done nothing other than bury their developing relationship, after all.

Because Deku was stubborn. That was his defining trait, wasn’t it? That was how he managed to get so far, even with all his disadvantages. Born without a quirk? Inherit one. Dream of becoming a hero? Get accepted into the best hero training school in Japan. Admire All Might? Become his heir. Want to save lives? Save them.

Break all your bones and cause irreversible damage to your arms in the process? Occupational hazard. Spend years having Katsuki either ignore him or tell him mean shit to bring him down? Shrug it off and keep going.

That was the kind of person Deku was.

Trying to argue with him on that would be equivalent to have an unstoppable force meet an unmovable object. When Deku set his mind to a goal, he did everything in his power to achieve it. No matter the cost.

And that was what scared Katsuki.

Deku's desire and determination were so absurdly strong that he didn't obey boundaries, or limits, or common sense. He was always willing to do *everything* to achieve what he wanted – whether it was jumping at a villain to save Katsuki, even though it was quirkless; whether it was convincing Half'n'Half to use his left side in a fight, even though he knew that would fuck him up and make him lose; whether it was launching himself at a Villain-ridded vortex just to save Katsuki *again*, even though he had just been beaten into a pulp.

Whether it was taking a blow in Katsuki's place, even though that almost cost him his life.

There was just no saving it, was there? Deku would just keep throwing himself into danger over and over and over again, and, as it seemed, Katsuki being involved only made him act even more reckless.

He didn't have the time to think about what that meant – he didn't have the time to sit around and debate that with Deku. They had already wasted too much time, and they had already lost an opportunity to escape because of their stupid arguing.

So Katsuki shook his head, expressing his disagreement. Then, he spun on his heels and walked away without a word.

No use fighting over this. That had never worked out for either of them, and it probably never would.

"Kacchan?", Deku asked, confused, following him.

"We don't have time for this crap", he said simply, sharply, not looking back. "We already lost a chance to escape because of this shitty discussion you insist on having, right in the middle of a villain attack".

"I'm not insisting –"

"Cut it out", Katsuki interrupted, angry. "If you ain't gonna do as I say, then do me a favor and don't get in my way".

Izuku paused.

"I can help", he insisted, sounding angry. "I just proved that to you. The fact that I'm quirkless right now can be even used as an advantage –"

“An advantage to what? To get yourself killed?”, Katsuki snorted out a humorless laugh. *Don’t argue don’t argue don’t argue don’t argue don’t argue –*

“An advantage to *help* you”, Deku retorted with no hesitation, fierce. “No one seems to remember me from the Sports Festival, and if they do, they didn’t recognize me. If that villain sent out word that I’m quirkless, they won’t perceive me as a threat, and then I can –“

“What, you want me to use you as *bait* now?”, Katsuki turned his head to look at him. “Hang you up from your bony ankles and dangle you in front of the villains to see which one takes a bite first? Just how fucking self-sacrificial *are* you, shitty nerd? I’m not gonna stand around and let you –“

“Don’t *do* this again!”, Izuku snapped, voice raising an octave, and Katsuki couldn’t recall ever hearing the nerd sound so assertive.

He paused, narrowing his eyes.

“Don’t do this again, Kacchan”, Deku said, firm, and was that… *reprimand* in his voice? “I’m not letting you”.

Katsuki scoffed, scornful.

“I don’t need your fucking *permission* –”

“I can tell you the *same*”, he interrupted, fierce.

Katsuki huffed out a half-amused, half-indignant breath at this.

“No, you *fucking* can’t”, he barked out through gritted teeth. He really didn’t want to waste even more time arguing, but Deku just wouldn’t let him catch a break from that, would he? “Because you’re so caught up in your delusion of proving your worth that you can’t even put two and two together and *think rationally* for once”, he tapped at his own temple for emphasis. “You’re so worried about *your* shitty ego that you can’t see that the only way you can possibly help me like this is by fucking going out and calling the pros. And I know that it’s probably my fault you ended up a desperate wannabe-overachiever with no concept of self-preservation, but I don’t give a *shit* right now. If you don’t wanna fucking go and call the pros, suit yourself. I’m following my plan through, and you do whatever the hell you want”.

He walked away again. Deku was silent for a moment before following him.

“Kacchan –“

“Don’t talk to me”.

“I am *trying*–“

“Don’t you fucking talk to me!”, Katsuki exploded, pointing a finger at Deku’s face. Deku took a step back at the sudden twist, but kept his ground, staring at Katsuki with big eyes that were shocked and determined at the same time.

Katsuki turned around again, walking faster in his rage.

Deku's eyes were open.

His face was slack, stuck in a ridiculous expression that was a mixture of pain and surprise, lips parted slightly and eyes half-lidded. Beneath the lids, Katsuki found a familiar green which lacked its even more familiar liveliness. No, Deku's eyes were cold and empty, deprived of its usual spark and emotion.

Deku's eyes were dead.

Katsuki reached the front of the deposit room, Deku glued to his heels and sounding like he was about to keep up with the fucking argument. But, in reality, the annoying sounds he was making with his mouth became a background noise to Katsuki – because, to his surprise, Jirou was on her knees with a glassy look on her face, Whatshisname sitting next to her and looking like he had just regained consciousness. Kaminari was still knocked out between them, and Jirou seemed to be trying to check him over for injuries despite her own dazedness.

Katsuki deflated, staring at the girl for a split moment before dashing towards her in a heartbeat, leaving the stubborn, rambling Deku behind.

"Oi, Ears", he called, relief evident in his voice, even if he did try to hide it.

She turned her groggy face to look at him with sluggishness, and relief washed over her expression when she spotted her friend approaching her.

"Bakugou", she said, the name coming off a bit slurred, her voice hoarse. He crouched down in front of her.

"How long have you been up?", he asked, taking her face roughly between his calloused hands and trying to check her pupils as best as he could. Jirou seemed startled at the sudden touch, blushing slightly, but before it could get weird(er), Katsuki let go of her – a bit too harshly, but not on purpose.

"Don't know", she shook her head slightly, sniffing and still looking a bit off. "The first… Uh, the first thing I remember after I woke up was hearin' you and Midoriya yell at each other".

Katsuki huffed, rolling his eyes.

"That doesn't narrow it down".

"Wha' happened?", Jirou swallowed dry, one hand leaning on Kaminari's chest as if to make sure he was breathing. She looked around, squinting at their surroundings. "Where are we? And…", she slurred. "Why's that guy tied up?", she nodded somewhere behind Katsuki.

He craned his neck to see the first villain he had knocked out, still unconscious and tied up next to a nearby shelf.

"Ok, long story short because we don't have the fucking time", Katsuki said. "Villain attack".

Jirou's eyes widened.

"We're in the deposit room on the underground of the museum building", he continued. "You and Deku were gone too long so I came looking for you. I have no idea what is happening upstairs right now, but the sound guy kidnapped you. We think he has a quirk that knocks people out, kind of drugs them or something. The wristband thing was a scam to lure you away because of your quirk. Deku saw you being dragged, came looking for you, got himself knocked out and captured too in the process. I found you two and whoever this guy is", he nodded at Whatshisname, who blinked sluggishly at him. "And then I knocked out the villains who came in after that. One of them said something about making people forget All Might or some shit, so I guess that's the kind of crap we're dealing with today".

Jirou blinked at him, trying to keep up with everything she was hearing. Her eyes were still glassy and her brain was still going through the process of properly waking up, but eventually she nodded.

"Ok," she said, swallowing dry again and looking tense. She looked a bit more sober out of a sudden – whatever had knocked her out was still wearing off. She frowned. "Shit… O-Ok".

"Yeah", Katsuki said. "The villains brought Dunce Face in right before I took them on, so I think it will take him a while to wake up, since he was knocked out after you two", he scoffed. "I also think knocking the villain out made the effect of his quirk wear off faster… Which would explain why you two woke up out of the blue now, when you didn't twitch even when I slapped you in the face", he pointed Whatshisname with an analytical look before turning back to Jirou, who had raised her fingers to her cheek.

"In that case, Kaminari-kun should wake up faster than they did", Izuku stepped into the talk, approaching them more closely, but also cautiously. "That will give us some time to think and come up with a proper plan –"

"I've already told you what the plan is", Katsuki cut him off harshly, glaring up at him and getting to his feet in order to face him properly. "And if you wanna sit around and wait until Dunce Face wakes up, by my fucking guest. Ears", he said, glaring at Deku for a while longer before he turned back towards the girl. "Can you stand up?"

Jirou raised her eyebrows and nodded compliantly, turning to push herself to her feet. Katsuki gave her a hand anyway, pulling her up, whereas Whatshisname managed to get up on his own, even if he swayed a bit on his feet.

"What are we going to do?", the guy asked, clearly confused and a little scared. "We – We should probably call the pros –"

"The signal is jammed", Deku provided. "We can't reach anyone, not even our friends upstairs".

"Crap", Jirou sighed, squeezing her eyes shut as she tried to regain balance. She leaned a bit on Katsuki for support as she took a hand to her throbbing temple and hissed. "We're gonna need to do something, then".

“That’s the plan, Ears”, Katsuki said, holding out an arm for her to lean on as she got a hold of herself. “At least now there’s only one unconscious body for us to carry”.

“Ok, but you keep talking about the plan and – what – what exactly *is* the plan?”, she frowned at him, letting go of his arm but still looking uncomfortable, even if more sober.

“I’ll help you guys out of the building, then I’ll go back upstairs and keep the shitty villains from doing whatever it is they’re planning to do while you call the pros for backup”, Katsuki provided simply, hearing – and ignoring – the way Deku sighed softly from somewhere behind him.

“But – I mean”, Jirou frowned. “This is a pretty big convention. The museum has been announced months ago and lots of people were looking forward to the opening. It’s a big deal. The pros must have noticed something is wrong by now”.

“The assholes were real discreet about it”, Katsuki said over his shoulder as he walked towards Kaminari. “I only noticed something was wrong because you were taking too long to come back and Round Face said something about Deku being missing. Plus, Ponytail said one of the tech guys who came in after you left is the same guy who caused that shit in the park back at my birthday, so I knew that couldn’t have been a coincidence”.

Jirou’s eyes widened again.

“The – The guy with the sound quirk? Who caused the incident?”, she asked, surprised.

“Yeah. The one and only”, Katsuki scoffed, crouched beside Kaminari.

“So…”, Jirou blinked, looking fully awake now. “They… It… It wasn’t an accident?”

Katsuki craned his neck to look at her. Then, he glared at Deku.

“No”.

He turned back to Kaminari.

“Point is”, Katsuki continued after a brief, awkward pause. “To anyone outside the building, nothing looks off. It’s not like they put out a big banner saying “Villain Attack in Progress!” or some shit – all they did was lock the auditorium after everyone was in, which was apparently expectable, and jam the damn signal. So there’s no reason why anyone outside would call a pro just yet, and no one can do it from the inside. They’ll probably do whatever it is they’re planning on doing during the time scheduled for the speech, which is –“

“One hour”, Jirou said. Katsuki gritted his teeth at the interruption, but mentally counted to ten and nodded.

“And nothing will seem off to anyone outside in that meantime. Meaning – we need to get out in order to call for help. If it was up to me, I’d just go upstairs and blow all those fucking villains to hell, but –“, he huffed, glaring at the floor. Then, he turned to look at Jirou again. “I’m already walking a thin line. If I do something like that without supervision or a proper hero license, I’ll definitely be kicked out of UA”.

Jirou gave him a look that was half-concerned, half-sympathetic.

“Didn’t you just say you knocked out the villains who showed up here?”

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“Yeah, but I used my damn *fists*, not my quirk. Not only was that self-defense, but if it gets me in trouble, it will have nothing to do with my hero license. Not sure that’ll be the case if we face off against too many of them at once”.

“All right”, she nodded, serious. “So what’s the plan again? Detailed version, please”.

Katsuki consciously avoided looking at Deku when he answered.

“We get to the emergency stairs. They’re not too far from this room. We go up to the first floor, I help you four out from there and watch your backs for any villains on surveillance. If anyone engages, I take them out as quietly as possible. Then, I sneak back all the way up to the auditorium and stall the villains while you assholes get help”.

“Wait, wait, wait, wait”, Jirou frowned at him. “Why are you going alone?”

“Because it’s easier for one person to sneak into a villain’s lair than five, dumbass”, Katsuki scoffed. “And you’re too shy to do the stalling”.

“But do you have any idea what these villains are doing up there?”, Whatshisname asked, nervous.

“No. But the guys down here said something about hating All Might and wanting everyone to forget him, so let’s assume it has to do with that. Since they decided to kidnap people and lock them up in auditoriums, I’m assuming they don’t want to call too much attention, otherwise they’d be destroying shit and being noisy about it as villains usually are during this sort of thing. I think those guys are up to something shadier than that, they probably think they’re smart. People who think they’re smart love to brag about it and blabber, which means they’ll probably be easier to stall without having to start a fight, at least until people with permanent licenses get here. And stalling usually works better when it’s only one person doing it”, he gave Jirou a pointed look.

“I don’t know about this, Bakugou”, Jirou frowned. “I think I should go with you. I could be your ears”.

“Are you really making a fucking hearing-loss joke right now?”, Katsuki squinted, causing Jirou to roll her eyes.

“It’s *not* a joke. I’m being serious”, Jirou protested. “I should go with you and give you a hand. It’s safer if I’m there to look out for incoming; that way we won’t be caught by surprise”.

Katsuki studied her face for a few moments, seeming reluctant, before crossing his arms above his chest. That actually sounded reasonable, and Jirou was mostly a discreet person. He already knew he could count on her, so he nodded briefly.

“*Fine*. But just you. And that’s non-negotiable”, he added firmly, putting a special effort into turning his head to glare at Izuku.

Izuku glared back at him, seeming ready to get into another argument, but Jirou stopped him.

“What about you, Midoriya?”, Jirou frowned, turning to Izuku with a worried look and holding a gentle hand to his arm. “Are you all right? How’s your head?”

“I’m all right, Jirou-san”, he told her reassuringly, even if the drying blood still covering half of his face and the piece of duct tape sealing the gash on his forehead didn’t make his words sound too convincing. “The villain who got me wasn’t the same who got you, so he had to knock me out in a different way”.

“And you’re concussed?”, Jirou’s frown deepened.

“No”, he said, glaring at Katsuki, at the same time Katsuki glared back at him and said “Yes”.

Awkward silence. They continued to glare at each other.

“Kind of”, Deku complied, shrugging and meeting Jirou’s eyes again. “But I’m getting better”.

“Sure you are, shitty Deku. You looking like you’re about to fucking keel over is just your new fashion trend, right?”, Katsuki scoffed from the distance.

Awkward pause.

“Ok, guys”, Jirou sighed, sensing how the atmosphere in the room was growing tense. “Can we *please* not do this right now?”

“You tell that to shitty Deku”, Katsuki scowled, taking a step closer to them. “He’s the one who keeps insisting he should stay here instead of going out to get help. *And* the one who fucking lost us an escape opportunity because of his shitty stubbornness”.

“That’s *not* what I did”, Izuku protested, offended. “I was just saying I think I can help more if I stay –“

“Oh, so you can think, now?”

“Ok, now I’m serious, can you two please stop –“, Jirou tried.

“*You’re* the one who’s not thinking, Kacchan”, Izuku protested, taking a step closer to him. “I really don’t know why you act like this whenever there’s a crisis going on, but I think we should focus on the situation at our hands! I was just saying I can help more by staying here than by going out to make a call, and *you’re* the one who’s too stubborn to admit I’m right, even though I *just* helped you!”

“And *I* was just saying you’re an idiot who doesn’t know better than to throw yourself at death’s arms at any given opportunity without giving a shit whether you’ll live or die!”

“Yes, because that’s what heroes do!”

“You’ve got a fucked-up view of what a hero is!”

“That’s rich coming from you! You’re the one who says you’ll surpass All Might, even though you keep shouting at people to *die* and *go to hell* all the time!”

“At least I’m not actively trying to break my fucking bones and get myself killed at every single opportunity! How’s *that* supposed to fucking help anyone?!”

“That’s *not* what I’m doing! I’m aware of the danger, but I won’t run away because of it! I was just saying I should come along because they’ll be less suspicious of me than they will be of you, since you were literally the winner of the Sports Festival *and* all over the news because of the League of Villains! And that villain back there said he knew you, and he *thanked* you, so you’re obviously much more of a target than I am! They didn’t even care about me enough to tie me up properly!”

“Yeah, and what are you gonna do to stop these villains, huh? You’re barely even recovered –”

“Well, and what are *you* gonna do? You just said it yourself you can’t blow them up or you’ll be expelled, so what is it *you* can do to them in these circumstances that I can’t?”

Katsuki was caught off guard, and his second-long hesitation made a smug look appear on Deku’s face. It only lasted for a split second before Deku realized what he had done and suppressed his smile, but the damage was done. Katsuki’s nostrils flared, and he saw red.

“You fucking piece of –“

“For god’s sake, Bakugou, Midoriya –“, Jirou said, placing herself between the two boys before they could get at each other’s throats. “Can we *please* just focus –“

“God, what is it with you UA kids?!”, Whatshisname asked, looking shocked and confused.

“You can call me how many names you want; it won’t change the fact that I’m right about this one, Kacchan! All of us here have our hands tied because of the hero permit, so I don’t see what’s so problematic about me tagging along with you!”

“Because you could fucking *die*!”

“So could you!”

“As *if*, Deku! You really think I’m about to be taken off by a bunch of extras –“

“Well, I’m not risking it!”

“Oh, yeah, and what are you gonna do about it? Throw yourself in front of me like an unsolicited human shield like you did last time?”

“Better than let you die!”

Katsuki jumped at Izuku again, ready to strike him, but Jirou held him back with one firm hand to his chest.

“Don’t you fucking *dare* say that, you piece of crap!”, he yelled, full of rage.

“Stop! Fighting!”, Jirou commanded.

“It’s the truth! I want to be there for you –“

“And I want you to mind your own business! I know damn well how to take care of myself, and I don’t need *you* of all people to hang around trying to sacrifice yourself for me because you think I’m incapable of winning a fucking fight!”

“*God,* this is not it, why do you *always* – why do you have to – this has *nothing* to do with winning or losing, Kacchan, it has to do with the fact that *I’m* training to be a hero too, and situations like this are going to be as much of a part of my life than they’re going to be a part of yours! You can’t keep trying to bench me forever!”

“I’ll stop benching you when you stop trying to kill yourself every time something slightly dangerous happens!”

“That’s not what I’m trying to do! How many times do I have to say –”

“Guys, *enough –“*

“You know I’m right; you just don’t want to admit it!”, Izuku continued. “And now Jirou-san and that guy are awake, and they can be the ones to go out and call for help! So tell me *one* reason I can’t stay here and help you!”

“You wanna know a fucking reason? I’ll give you a fucking reason”, Katsuki snarled, pushing Jirou so she wouldn’t be in the way. He advanced on Deku. “I don’t want you to fucking *die* on me again and get *pissed* at me when I’m forced to do something shitty in order to save your dumb ass from kicking the bucket for the hundredth time!”

“Guys –“

“And I don’t want to leave our friends behind and abandon you here, in danger and with no one to watch your back, when there are other people who can go out and call the pros instead of me!”

“You really think so *much* of yourself –“

Zap!!

Before they could keep going with that endless argument, Jirou used her jacks to shock both Katsuki and Izuku, like she often did with Kaminari and Mineta. Both joys jolted in surprise and pain, twitching and yelping from the sudden course of electricity. Once they were finally silent, she retrieved her jacks and glared at the two of them, looking furious.

“I’m *done* with your dick measuring contest on who cares the most about the other”, she scolded, serious and, apparently, fully back to normal now that the effect of the villain’s quirk had passed. The look on her face was absolutely disapproving. “This is a *villain invasion*. We were kidnapped and there are *lives* at stake. This is not the time to keep whining at each other like you always do”.

Katsuki glared at her, but Izuku had the decency to look ashamed as he lowered his eyes to the floor.

“Bakugou”, Jirou continued, glaring at the explosive boy, “get a damn *grip*. This is not the time for you to have a freak out session. Midoriya”, she glared at the ashamed nerd, “stop being so stubborn. Bakugou’s right about your recklessness. You two are training to be heroes, for fuck’s sake, so *act like it*. And you”, she pointed at Whatshisname, who had wandered off a bit far from the arguing trio, “stop wasting your time with that phone, he said the signal’s jammed”.

Whatshisname looked embarrassed and lowered his arm. He had outstretched his hand holding his phone up towards the ceiling as a way to get reception, but upon Jirou’s scolding, he put the device back into his pocket and approached her.

“I think Kaminari is waking up”, the guy provided, clearly trying to be useful as a way to make up for his embarrassment.

“Kaminari”, Jirou corrected gently, but nodded her thanks at the guy. Without offering the pair as much as a second glance, Jirou walked past Katsuki and Izuku and knelt down beside her friend. “Hey. Hey, dumbass. Are you with me?”

Kaminari simply groaned something that sounded suspiciously like “*wheeey*”, stirring a bit and turning his head to the side, but not opening his eyes. That was more than Katsuki had earned of Jirou when she was unconscious, which could mean the dipshit was actually on the route to waking up.

“Well”, Jirou sighed, getting back to her feet and turning to face the pair again. “At least your yelling was useful for *something*”, she crossed her arms above her chest, giving them both the same disapproving look from before. “He’s waking up. I think we can afford a couple more minutes in here until he’s able to walk on his own. It’s better than having to carry him around”.

Izuku lowered his head again, but Katsuki scoffed in annoyance.

“Look, Ears –“

“Midoriya’s right”, she cut him off abruptly.

Silence.

The tone of her voice made it seem like she was almost *daring* Katsuki to argue. Katsuki narrowed his eyes at her. When he didn’t take the bait and remained silent, she continued.

“Right now, you’re more recognizable than him, especially if one of the villains knew you by name”, she said. “If a villain spots you first, they’ll immediately attack without hesitation. If they spot Midoriya first, he might be able to stall them enough for us to think of something. And since neither of you – *or* us – will be able to use our quirks on the villains up there, all we can do is try to win the pros some time, maybe sabotage the villains’ plans, I don’t know. I can do far-distance surveillance, Midoriya can lead the way towards the stairs to ensure the path is clear, and you should stay behind to cover our backs”.

Katsuki scoffed at the last sentence. Yeah, send the weakest, quirkless guy on front and keep Katsuki in the back. As if he’d ever agree to that.

(Fairly enough, Ears didn’t know Deku was currently quirkless, but the plan was still stupid.)

“Don’t act like you’re in fucking charge, Ears”, Katsuki interrupted her with something akin to disdain in his voice. Because what the hell did she think she was doing, undermining his authority like that?! He was in control of the situation. He was the one calling the shots, not her, *especially* because she seemed to be super ok with putting stupid Deku in danger, even if she *knew* how Katsuki felt about that. “I already told you he’s not coming and that’s not fucking negotiable”.

She raised an eyebrow at him.

“I’m not *acting* like anything; I’m just trying to think logically –“

“You don’t even know what’s happening up there! You literally just woke up –“

“And *you’re* not thinking straight, so that makes us even!”, she snapped.

They glared at each other. Whatshisname seemed extremely uncomfortable from where he was now kneeling beside the stirring Kaminari; Deku was watching them intensely, eyes darting between the two friends. Katsuki’s snarl was almost feral, but Jirou didn’t falter.

“Don’t act like this is the time to boost your ego. You’re awesome, and you’re great at strategizing, but you’re not using your *head* right now. And I’m begging you to just take a breath and think about every single anger management session you’ve had so far, because I really need you on this, Bakugou”, she shook her head, sincere. “The *you* you. The one who grins at villains because he knows he’s going to win, and the one who uses *everything* at hands to make sure he doesn’t lose. *Including* Midoriya, if it comes down to it”.

He glared daggers at her, hating that she was right and that he *knew* she was right. His hands were tightened into fists and he was clenching his jaw so intensely that a vein was popping in his temple. His body was trembling all over from all sorts of emotions, and only then, upon Ears’ words, that Katsuki realized he was breathing hard – way too hard.

“She’s right, Kacchan”, Deku stepped in, a serious yet pleading look on his face. “We need to work together on this. And we’ll need everything we’ve got to protect our friends upstairs”.

He glared at Deku, nostrils flaring. He was overflowing with too many emotions, too many feelings, and there was electricity running across his body, ready to burst out of him. He held

back.

He needed to *focus*.

“Midoriya is a hero in training too, Bakugou”, Jirou pointed out, stern. “You can’t keep trying to protect him forever. I know that what happened last year was tough on you, but – it’s part of our job. It’s what we’re training to be”, she offered him an almost apologetic shrug.

His nostrils flared. He felt cornered, tense – and incredibly defensive, on the top of everything else. His fists were so tight he could feel his fingernails digging into his palms. Everything was spiraling out of control, because no one was *listening to his goddamn plan*. He was having a hard time not flipping it completely.

“So everyone’s against me, huh?”, he said, voice low, hoarse, and guttural. Restrained, like he felt. “You all sided together and decided to fucking go against me –“

“This is not what we’re doing and you know it”, Jirou cut him off, impatient and sounding almost offended. “This isn’t about *you”*.

Katsuki glared at her.

They were running out of time. They needed to make a decision and get a fucking move on – but he was clearly outnumbered on this.

The only things he wanted were: 1. Ruin the shitty villains’ fucking plan and rescue everyone; 2. Make sure Deku, Jirou, and everyone else was safe. From the way things were going, he wouldn’t be able to do one thing without compromising the other, and there was no one to back him up. No one to agree with him that allowing Deku to stay there instead of running away would be a fucking mistake, no one to agree that he was right to insist on keeping nerdo-kun safe.

And it fucking drove him insane, because his feelings were getting harder and harder to control and he felt like a dam about to burst from the pressure, from the emotions, from the *feelings*. Feelings of fear, and rage, and anger, and worry, and anticipation, and victory, all bundled together and overlapping with each other. And he was about to lose it, he could tell, but he *couldn’t* lose it because there were people who needed him, and if Deku was about to throw himself headfirst into danger –

Take a swan dive

– despite his best efforts, despite his warnings, then Katsuki needed to ensure that he would at least be there to do some damage control.

Fuck.

“Midoriya –c’mon”, Jirou said with authority when a few moments passed and Katsuki did nothing other than stand there and glare.

Katsuki saw red as Deku rushed past Jirou compliantly, heading towards Kaminari, whose eyes were finally opening.

“Huh…?”, Kaminari asked, disoriented, when he saw Jirou grabbing his shoulder in a dark, foreign room. Deku and Whatshisname lingered behind her, staring at him. “W-What…?”

“You were captured by villains”, Jirou provided briefly. “We’re under attack. The museum is compromised. Can you stand?”

Kaminari blinked at her.

“Huh…?”, he repeated, and Jirou sighed.

“The *museum*. Remember that? The All Might expo?”, she raised her eyebrows at him.

Kaminari blinked, frowning.

“Uh… I…”, he stuttered, clearly groggy.

“Give him a few moments”, Deku suggested. “For the drug to wear off”.

“We don’t have a few moments”, Whatshisname said, voice trembling from anxiety. “You guys keep talking about how the villains might be looking for us and how we should get going fast –“

“Yeah, because we ain’t got time to lose”, Katsuki scoffed. “Just grab him and let’s go. He can recover while we get the fuck out of here”.

Jirou snapped her head to look at him. Then, she spared Kaminari another glance, a decisive look appearing on her face.

“What… Where are we…?”, Kaminari frowned again, glassy eyes trying to gather his surroundings. He seemed to be way more disoriented than Jirou had been, probably because he woke up sooner than she did, thanks to the villain losing conscience.

“At the deposit downstairs”, Jirou explained patiently. “But we’re moving now”.

“Huh”, Kaminari blinked in surprise. “Is tha’ why you were takin’ so long?”, he slurred. Jirou frowned as she passed one of his arms around her shoulder to hoist him up.

“What?”, she asked, at the same time Whatshisname jumped into action and helped her by taking Kaminari’s other arm. Together, they lifted him off the ground, securing him gently between them. Kaminari stumbled and struggled to put his weight into his feet.

“You – weren’ comin’ back”, he provided, head falling limply and gluing his chin to his chest, only for him to perk his head up again in a matter of seconds, groggy. “So I came lookin’”.

“Yeah, we’re gonna talk about that later”, she groaned, adjusting his arm around her neck. “For now, let’s get going”.

“Why’s everythin’ spinnin’?”, Kaminari frowned as they started moving towards the door.

“It’ll be over soon”, Jirou told him comfortingly. “Just give it a few seconds”.

“’Kay”, he complied, trying and failing to take steps along with Jirou and the other guy carrying him. After a few failed attempts, he gave up on walking and simply allowed himself to be dragged along.

Jirou gave Katsuki a meaningful look.

“Let’s go”, she said simply.

Deku jumped into action and followed the trio towards the door, and so did Katsuki. Once they were all huddled close to the door frame, Jirou snuck one of her jacks out through the narrow opening beneath the door and jammed it on the floor, hearing for possible incoming people.

Her eyes were closed and her brow was scrunched in concentration as she listened to the exterior of the room. A few seconds passed before she blinked and found Izuku’s glance.

“I don’t hear anyone, but that could be a trick of the villains”, she announced. Izuku nodded.

“Leave it to me”, he said, twisting the knob and opening the door slowly. Before Katsuki knew, he was walking out as silently as possible.

Katsuki made to walk out after him, but Jirou held him back by placing her free hand against his chest.

Katsuki turned his head to glare at her. She stared back at him with honesty, still supporting half of Kaminari’s weight.

“I’m not doing this to hurt you”, she said simply, quietly.

Katsuki couldn’t help but to scoff.

“Fuck you”, he sniffed.

He tried to walk away again, but she gripped his shirt.

“I’m not”, she reinforced. “I wouldn’t. You know that”.

He scoffed again, grabbing her hand and removing it from his shirt. He stayed where he was, though, glaring daggers at her.

“If he *dies* –“

“Bakugou”, she interrupted him, serious. “He won’t die”.

He continued to glare, a vein popping in his temple.

“I promise. Ok?”, Jirou continued, determined and concerned. “It will be ok. But if you keep trying to bench him, he’ll just push himself harder and harder. You *know* him. If you forbid

him to go, he'll just do it anyway when you're not looking. And *then* he might get himself killed, because no one will be there to watch his back. This way, by us letting him do something to help, he won't go behind our backs. And you'll be able to keep an eye on him".

Katsuki stared at her. Had this really been her plan all along? To give Izuku just a little bit, just enough to keep him busy, instead of denying him altogether and having him rebel? Just so he could be satisfied with what he could get? So he wouldn't end up killing himself by trying to prove his worth?

Like he could *ever* be satisfied? Like he would ever feel like he was good enough? Like he would ever be contented with just giving them a little hand?

Like he would ever stop running right into danger?

"Right. You *clearly* don't know shitty Deku", he scorned.

"I know Midoriya's worth", she said. "I know he's skilled and capable of looking after himself. But I also know he's reckless, and he's determined, and he's stubborn, and he's *recovering*", she continued, serious. "I know all that. But if we force him out of here, he will find his way back to you. You *know* he will, he always does. And *then* he could be in real danger", she argued. "This way, he'll be right beside you, which is the safest place he could be during a villain attack".

"Yeah, because that worked out so well for him in the past", Katsuki scoffed, scornful. "Being by my side. Throwing himself in front of me, taking blows in my place".

"You're a different person now", she said. "And you don't need to treat him like porcelain".

"You too with this shitty talk or porcelain?", he scoffed.

"I'm serious. He's strong, Bakugou, he's not some damsel in distress. Let him do what he can do while concussed and recovering, and watch his back while he's at it. He wants to be a hero, just as much as we do".

Yeah, but he doesn't have his quirk right now. And you don't know anything about that, so shut the fuck up, Ears.

Not having a quirk never stopped Deku from trying to save him, though. Which is what concerned him. The lesser means Deku had to protect himself, the more danger he seemed to attract. Memories of how Deku hadn't hesitated to throw himself at that Sludge Villain to save him flooded his mind.

Why are you here?!

You looked like you were asking for help…!

"I know he fucking does", Katsuki said. "That's what I'm worried about. He thinks he can save everyone".

"Don't you think that about yourself, too?"

Katsuki narrowed his eyes at her.

“Because I *can*”.

“So can he”, she pointed out. “You know, for someone who insists you don’t look down on him anymore, you sure seem to doubt Midoriya’s potential”.

Katsuki scoffed.

“He’s fucking *concussed*”.

“He seems a bit slow, and he definitely needs to get his head checked out, but this is a villain invasion”, Jirou argued. “I think he can handle helping me get you upstairs. Then, you run the show on your own”.

Jirou took a step closer to him, dragging Kaminari and a clearly awkward Whatshisname along.

“We’re both worried about you, Bakugou. And we’re both trying to help you. You don’t have to do this alone. You don’t have to go through *anything* alone”.

Katsuki looked away from her, not sure how he should – or wanted to – react to that.

Jirou sighed.

“You two are stubborn. And you two want the same thing”, she said. “So let’s use that and go save those people”.

Izuku appeared on the door of the deposit again as if on cue, an urgent look on his face.

“There’s nothing weird on the next two corridors and all the elevators are on the top floor. We should go while things are clear”, he announced.

Jirou nodded at him.

“*Hai*”.

She rushed out with Kaminari and Whatshisname, Katsuki watching them go. And while he knew she had a point, while he *knew* they needed to focus on their priority, which was to rescue everyone upstairs, there was still something he couldn’t stop thinking about.

“I’m losing him!”, Recovery Girl screamed as Deku began to flatline.

Deku was dying. His heart had stopped.

“Bakugou shonen!”, All Might roared.

He looked at Deku. His eyes were rolled back, his lips parted and coated in blood. His chest wasn’t moving.

His heart wasn’t beating.

Ok. Deep breaths. Katsuki could do this. He could do this. Everything would be fine, because he'd go upstairs, he would fight the villains and save everyone like All Might would if he was here. And he'd manage to keep an eye on Deku while he was at it, like Ears explained, since, apparently, he had no say in that.

Didn't he want to be a better hero than All Might? Didn't he want to surpass him? Didn't he want to become number 1?

Then he needed to focus. And *not* let his feelings get the best of him.

He marched out of the deposit, closing the door behind him and using his quirk to heat up his hand while he grabbed the doorknob. The metal became red and melted away in a few moments, sealing the villains inside – at least for the time being. When he turned around, Jirou was waiting with Whatshisname and a squirming Kaminari by the intersection, Deku probably ahead of them checking their next pathway.

Deep breaths. Strategize. Focus.

Katsuki reached the trio, spotting Deku ahead, near the other intersection that led towards the emergency stairs. He was looking around the corridor, checking if they had any incoming, while Jirou listened too with her jacks shoved on the floor.

Deku looked stronger. His muscles were definitely more well-shaped and protuberant – not back to normal, not yet, but… *there* –, he looked quicker and more agile, he looked… apt. He wasn't the same skinny kid who had gone to Katsuki's birthday in the park all those months ago, sustaining a fever and allergies that caused him to skip classes.

He wasn't the same skeletal figure that had just been cleared out of the hospital, unable to speak properly or to walk on his own. He wasn't the same quirkless teen that walked around with hunched shoulders and a lowered head.

Deku's chin was lifted up, and his eyes were sparkling with life and determination. Despite his concussion, he looked concentrated. And as he spun on his heels to signal that they could make a move, that their way was clear, Katsuki finally realized that maybe, just *maybe,* he had been a little bit wrong. Just a little bit.

Deku's eyes looked alive. And he looked ok.

Had Katsuki really been so blinded by his feelings that he didn't even consider this possibility? Had his concern for Deku's safety really knocked his brains out of his head?

Had he really been so stupid and emotional to the point of overprotecting Deku? Could he have compromised them, and his friends, and everyone who was upstairs just over a stupid concern?

What was *happening* to him? When did he become someone who prioritized *Deku* over everyone else? When did he become someone who prioritized Deku over being a hero? Over being number one? Over beating All Might? Over a goddamn *rescue*?!

His earlier fight with Deku in the deposit room had almost screwed everything – he thankfully managed to defeat the villains, but things could have easily gone south. He wouldn't even have had to fight the villains in the first place if they hadn't wasted so much time on arguing instead of escaping.

Since when did he stop being the Katsuki who was focused and who strategized and who thought before he acted and who did whatever he had to do in order to win to become… *this*? This stupid version who allowed *feelings* to take the best of him and to cloud his judgement –

Is that how you feel? Like your judgement is clouded?

He took in a shaky breath.

I feel like everything is clouded. Like everything I used to know about myself has changed, and I can't recognize me anymore. I told Deku I wasn't going to change, I wasn't going to become someone else, but – Didn't I? I mean, why do I care so much? And why do I care so much about him, specifically? Why can't I just bring myself to go back to not giving a shit and doing as I please?

Why? *Why?* Why did he care so much about Deku?

God. God, what was he doing? The thought of seeing Deku die scared him, but who was this person he'd become? Why was he thinking with his heart? What was his heart even doing, why was it beating so fast, why was it trying to climb its way up his throat –

"Bakugou", Jirou said.

He looked at her, eyes wide and brow scrunched up into a frown. He let out a breath he didn't even realize he had been holding.

She looked worried. Why was she worried?

"Are you ok?", she frowned, sounding urgent.

"Heeeey, Bakubro", Kaminari gave him a groggy smile and a small thumbs-up with the hand that was hanging from Jirou's shoulder.

"Guys", Izuku called from the far corner, his voice barely above a whisper as if not to call attention, and also completely unaware of what was happening to Katsuki from that distance. "We need to move!"

Focus. *Focus.* He needed to focus.

Why was he so scared? He was Bakugou fucking Katsuki, he didn't *do* scared. He didn't *have* to do scared. He was fine. They would be fine. He was amazing, he could take down every D-lister upstairs, they didn't even have to call the pros, he could do this, he could keep Deku and Ears and Dunce Face and everyone safe, he shouldn't be so nervous about *failure*, even if that was *all* he had been experiencing recently.

He marched past Jirou without answering her question, heading towards Deku. Then he kept on marching until he reached the stairs and when he reached the stairs, he began to climb them and when he began to climb them a hand grabbed him and he reacted on instinct and slapped it away and he kept on climbing and he needed to do this and he needed to get this over with and he kept on climbing –

“Kacchan, wait!”

Matte yo, Kacchan!

He squeezed his eyes shut and grimaced. The same hand grabbed him again, and before he could think about it, he was grabbing Deku by the front of his bloodied All Might birthday-gift shirt and slamming the boy’s back against the wall of the emergency stairs, his free hand leaning on the wall beside his head.

“Kacchan!”, Izuku exclaimed with wide, confused eyes, both hands shooting up to hold at Katsuki’s fist grabbing him. “What are you –“

“If you die, don’t shove it on my face”, Katsuki said abruptly, snarling as he held Deku, the expression on his face so intense it made him resemble a feral beast.

A pause. Deku continued to look at him with wide eyes.

“If you fail”, he continued, face twitching and voice constricted, “*don’t* put the blame on me”.

Because that was the reason why, right? Why he had overlooked how well Deku seemed to be doing now; why he had ignored Deku’s ability and Deku’s potential; why he hadn’t noticed that, while he was obviously concussed, the concussion didn’t seem to be anything other than mild. Why he kept insisting for him to leave, why they kept arguing over it, why he kept *looking down* on Deku, as Deku himself and Jirou had put.

It was because of the eyes. And the flatline sound. And the *death*. And Katsuki didn’t want to see that again. He didn’t want to fathom it; he didn’t want to be responsible for it. He didn’t want it to happen.

But no one else seemed to understand that. No one else *could*. And Katsuki was tired of worrying so much about it. He was fucking done, really. And he was done being judged for it, too.

Izuku continued to stare at him with wide eyes.

“I might have caused All Might’s end, but I won’t take the blame for yours”, he snarled, aware that Jirou, Kaminari and Whatshisname were watching from a few steps behind. “You hear me? I won’t take the blame for yours!”, he let go of Izuku’s shirt abruptly, making the boy stumble to the side. “You wanna go and be a fucking hero? You go and be a fucking hero. But let it be said that I don’t need your shitty help to beat these villains. You’re only going because you want to, so you own up to that, you hear me? I never needed your help and I never will! I can do it on my fucking own! You own that shit up!”

His words came out in the form of a whisper, since he didn't want them to be caught by the villains for something so stupid, but even his whispers still had passion and intensity. The anger within him was strong, his rage was making him crack. His emotions were about to erupt like a volcano, he could tell. He was struggling to keep everything at bay. He was struggling to deal with all those feelings on his own.

If only Deku could still take half the burden. If only he could share that weight with Katsuki, a weight he himself had inflicted, because before all this Katsuki had been faring well enough on his own, with his anger, and his rage, and his fury, but now this was all too much, he was feeling too much, and he was feeling *fear*, because he couldn't fail, not again. Not again. But he was tired of trying to convince people of that.

"I know you can", Izuku whispered seriously, leaning heavily on the wall behind him but looking comprehensive, like he had finally figured a big secret out.

The calm in his voice unsettled Katsuki. He turned to look at Izuku, who had his eyes fixed on Katsuki's trembling form.

"Whenever I think about victory", Izuku continued, serious, even if tears were making his eyes glisten. "I think about you. I think that's why I want to beat you in the hero charts – and that's why I know you *can* do this on your own".

Katsuki's nostrils flared.

"And that's also why *I* want to do something. I want to be like you. I've *always* wanted to be like you", he sniffed, shaking his head slightly. "I want to be someone who grins at their enemies because they know victory is certain. You've mastered the All Might smile without even trying, Kacchan, while I…", he trailed off, shaking his head again. "I want to be someone who people don't have to worry about so much. Someone who doesn't need anyone's help. Because the only reason I am here today is because I got help. A *lot* of people helped me. And I know a lot of people worry about me, too. And you said it yourself – I can't keep losing when so many people paved the way for me".

Katsuki's nose twitched.

" I want to do something out of my own credit, like *you* have always done", he continued. "I want to be a hero worthy of number one. I want to be a hero like All Might. I want", he let go of the wall and took a step closer to Katsuki. "To be the hero I always knew you would become".

Katsuki stared at him, breathing hard and still snarling. His face was twitching from the tension – so was his entire body. He was feeling too much. He was about to burst; he couldn't hold back everything he was feeling for much longer.

There was electricity running through him.

"I won't take the blame", he said again through gritted teeth, and he hated how it ended up sounding like he was trying to reassure himself. "I *won't*. I told you you don't have *shit* to prove, to me or to anyone else. You're doing this shit because you *want* to".

“You won’t have any blame to take”, Izuku said, still serious, but sounding infinitely more comprehensive, as if he had finally figured Katsuki out, after all those months.

(Katsuki wished).

“It will be fine. Everything will be fine”, Izuku added, offering Katsuki a wobbly smile.

Katsuki continued to glare.

“Because we are here, and we will *win*”.

Fuck.

He couldn’t believe Deku. He just *couldn’t*.

What was it about this damn nerd? How could it be that every single thing Katsuki had ever thought about him seemed to be wrong? What *was* the chance he would be so wrong about Deku, and for so many years? This had to be a scam. He couldn’t be wrong – Deku was making a fool out of him. He had to be.

But in his eyes, Katsuki only found honesty. And it had happened so long ago, but he had felt Deku’s feelings, once upon a time. And they had been confusing, and messy, and loud, but they had been real. Sincere. And there hadn’t been an ounce of scorn, or despise, or indifference in them.

They had been warm, and hopeful, and bright. Like Deku’s eyes were.

Why had he forgotten about that? About how Deku felt like sunny days and *hope*?

Katsuki scoffed and clicked his tongue, lowering his head. Izuku approached him further, but never touched him.

Katsuki found that he had been expecting Deku to. Expecting a touch to his shoulder, to his arm, or maybe even a hug. He wouldn’t fall so low as to ask for it, but… He had expected it. He would also never admit it, but it was a bit disappointing that none of that came.

“You ok?”, Deku asked, reassuring, but from a small distance. Katsuki scoffed.

“I’m telling you. Don’t blame me if you die this time”, he repeated for safe measure, but his tone was infinitely lighter than it had been just a few moments before. He finally looked up, and met Deku’s eyes.

“I’d never blame you, Kacchan”, he said, sincere. “And none of us will die; I promise”, he raised his pinky finger at Katsuki.

Katsuki narrowed his eyes at it before groaning and rolling his eyes.

“What are you, five?”

“Ok, suit yourself”, Deku shrugged, lowering his hand.

Jirou rolled her eyes, giving Whatshisname a look that said “don’t ask me about it”.

“Ok, are you guys done?”, she asked, impatient. “Can we keep going, now?”

“Yeah”, Katsuki said, voice still hoarse. “Let’s keep going”.

They continued to climb up the stairs.

“I hear two people. They’re talking, but I can’t tell what their quirks are just from that”, Jirou said, pulling her jack back and turning to look at the rest of the group. “They’re close to the front entrance. I didn’t hear anyone else, but we shouldn’t assume anything”.

“We should go there and see”, Izuku said. “Just to be sure we can take them”.

Katsuki scoffed, rolling his eyes. He tapped Izuku’s arm and stood up, pulling the door of the emergency stairs open and holding it open for Deku – something he would have never done for anyone a year prior. The duo left Jirou waiting with Whatshisname and the increasingly recovering Kaminari as they headed towards the front door.

The hallway of the first floor was empty and tranquil. There was no one around when they stepped out, just like Jirou had said, so the duo moved on, Izuku leading the way while Katsuki followed him close behind, guarding his back.

They turned on a corridor, and then on the next one. From there, they could see the front exit of the building, which was being guarded by only two men.

Either they were pretty fucking powerful, or the villains were just idiots who thought two people would be enough to guard the main exit.

(Katsuki was betting on a mix of the two answers).

They looked perfectly ordinary, but quirks could be deceiving. Maybe he and Deku would be able to overhear a bit of their conversation, see if they would reveal something compromising, before jumping into action.

Katsuki tapped Izuku’s shoulder, calling his attention. The boy turned to look at him as they took cover on the wall of the corridor.

“*If we take them down, we’ll have to be quick and quiet*”, Katsuki used sign language to tell Izuku. Izuku nodded briefly.

"*But we don't know what their quirks are yet. If we attack and miss, we could risk starting a fight, and it could go sideways*".

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

"*What are you suggesting, then?*"

"*That we find another way out"*, Izuku signed simply.

"*Through* where*, asshole? There isn't another way out"*.

"We could climb to the second floor and head to the window at the back of the building. There's no one guarding the back exit", he nodded at somewhere behind Katsuki. *"So it's not likely there's anyone guarding the second-floor back window. There, we can find a way to lower Kaminari-kun and the other guy to the ground. They can rush out to get help; we can keep heading upstairs"*.

Katsuki narrowed his eyes at Izuku, pensive.

"*Lowering them down would make us vulnerable for longer. We could be spotted, and we could be forced into a fight anyway"*.

"We can be spotted and forced into a fight at any given time, Kacchan".

"Well, my quirk is loud as fuck, dipshit. I can't use it to actually knock the villains out, but I can still use it as leverage. If we need to put up a fight, there's no way the entire building won't hear it. I managed to tone it down back at the deposit, which was literally underground, and we were still lucky no one heard it. I don't think we'll have the same luck up here".

"Well? Then don't use your quirk at all", Izuku shrugged, as if that was the most obvious solution ever.

A solution Katsuki hadn't even considered. Because yeah, he'd taken the downstairs villains out using martial arts and precise blows, but in his fight against the Drugger Villain he had still needed to use his explosions to propel himself mid-air and to change the course of his attacks. To think about getting into a real fight against a real villain, where his, Deku's, and everyone else's lives were at stake, without relying on his quirk, even as a backup…

He didn't know how to do it. His entire life, he'd been able to count on his quirk. All the time.

That wasn't Deku's case, of course. Which was why he was suggesting it.

"*I think the second floor is a safer option than here",* Izuku continued casually, unaware of Katsuki's thoughts*. "Actually, they can go out even more discreetly through there, since it's possible that the front door –"*

Suddenly, a loud static sound invaded their ears, making them flinch in perfect unison. Once again, it took Katsuki longer than it should have to realize the noise was coming from the walkie-talkie on his belt – *again*.

“Fuck, fuck, fuck”, he whispered under his breath, scrambling to grab the damn thing and silence it.

“ *– you copy? How – in the deposit? – through. You copy?*”, the person trying to communicate with him was saying, but the connection was breaking. By the time Katsuki managed to turn the device off, the two people standing guard at the front door had already noticed the sound.

“The hell was that?”, one of them said. “Did you hear it?”

“Yeah, man”, the other replied. “Think it was that kid who’s missing?”

“Could be. Better if you go check it out”.

“Why me?”

“Because you can capture him more easily, dipshit”.

Ok. Capture quirk. Not the ideal match in a situation where Katsuki couldn’t use his explosions, then.

“Ugh. Fine. But Soshi hasn’t come back yet, and they’re probably arguing down there again. Try to reach out for the suckers at the deposit while I’m out”.

“Yeah, leave it to me”.

Katsuki and Izuku exchanged one quick look before jolting back the way they came and rushing towards the emergency stairs.

When they re-entered it, Jirou stood up with expectation, but the sentiment was short-lived as Katsuki urgently gestured for her to climb up the stairs. With a confused frown, but blissfully with no complaint, she complied, being followed by Kaminari and Whatshisname while Katsuki and Izuku remained by the door, trying to overhear the villain’s approach.

The timing was perfect. Just as the trio disappeared on the upper floor, and just as Izuku tensed up and grabbed Katsuki’s forearm, the metallic grey door of the emergency stairs opened, inwards. They were standing right behind it, which meant the door itself blocked Katsuki and Izuku from the villain’s view.

They stood still as statues, Katsuki looking stoic and Izuku’s eyes wide as saucers. None of them dared to breathe. Jirou must have heard the villain coming, because the trio’s footsteps halted as well as soon as they were out of sight, lest the villain hear them.

With the door blocking Katsuki’s and Izuku’s view, they couldn’t see what the villain was doing, so it was impossible to know whether they had been caught or not.

Time seemed to drag, seconds becoming minutes, minutes becoming hours. Katsuki’s lungs were burning and begging for air. He could feel Izuku’s grip on his arm getting tighter and tighter with each passing second of silence. And all he could think in those excruciatingly long seconds was: *what if I didn’t turn the shitty walkie talkie off properly, what if it starts*

screaming again, what will we do then, if we knock this guy out the other villain will miss him, and he will probably come after him, which will clear our way out through the front door, unless he calls for backup, then we'll probably be screwed, because it's eleven fucking stairs up and it'll be fucking harder to get there with someone after us, and it will all be for nothing if there's no one outside to call the pros and send for aid, because I can't blow them all up or UA will kick me out –

"Tch", the villain said, slam-dunking Katsuki out of his thoughts and sending his brain on high-alert.

Then, the villain turned around and left, the heavy emergency stairs door dragging behind slowly, groaning, before it shut closed with a dull click.

He hadn't spotted them.

Katsuki and Izuku waited for a few seconds until they could no longer hear the villain's increasingly far-off footsteps. Then, they breathed out at the exact same time, relief washing over their faces. They panted together, leaning the back of their heads on the wall behind them.

"*Didn't you turn that thing off?*", Izuku signed at him, still panting, and nodded at the walkie on Katsuki's hip. Katsuki nodded.

"*I did*", he signed back, grabbing the walkie. Sparing it a look, he saw the screen was lit again – it had turned itself back on.

"What the fuck?", Katsuki whispered aloud, frowning at the device.

"*We should get going*", Izuku signed at him. "*Maybe Jirou-san can figure it out*".

Katsuki nodded, even if he was still frowning. Together, he and Deku climbed the stairs, finding Jirou, Kaminari, and Whatshisname waiting for them halfway to the level above. Katsuki noticed the relief washing over Jirou's face once she spotted them.

"What happened?", she whispered, frowning. "Were you guys followed?"

"Kind of", Katsuki whispered back. "The fucking walkie talkie went off, some D-lister was trying to reach it and the villains guarding the exit heard it", he said, handing her the device. "I had turned this shit off when I first grabbed it. It went off anyway when we were down at the deposit, so I turned it off again. It keeps turning itself back on".

Jirou inspected the device with an analytical look. She frowned.

"Huh. That's weird. I never saw something like this happen", she commented.

"Maybe it's someone quirk?", Deku suggested.

"Or it could be new tech", Whatshisname shrugged.

“Why don’t we just ditch it?”, Kaminari offered, sounding more sober – but still in a Kaminari-level of sobriety.

Katsuki and Izuku stared at him.

“So you’re back with us?”, Katsuki was the first one to speak, narrowing his eyes at Kaminari.

“Uh…”, Kaminari hesitated.

“He’s getting there”, Jirou intervened, still focused on analyzing the device.

“*Hey*. I’m pretty awake, now, thank you”, Kaminari defended himself.

“Whatever, Dunce Face. You shouldn’t even be here in the first damn place”, Katsuki rolled his eyes, stepping closer to Jirou. “So what do you think? Is it better if we ditch it, or can you use it to listen to the villains?”

“When the voice came through, they were asking something about the deposit”, Deku noted. “They’ll probably send someone there soon and realize we escaped”.

They all exchanged glances.

“Then we don’t have the time to figure this thing out”, Jirou nodded solemnly. “Not without risking having it go off and give us away again”.

He stretched out one of her jacks and plugged it into the walkie, attaching the device to her belt.

A pregnant pause.

“Leave it with me”, she explained as if it was obvious when everyone just stared at her. “With my jack jammed on it, I’ll be the only one who hears it when it goes off. This way we can know what they’re doing and where they are”.

“Oh”, Deku blinked. “That’s actually a good idea”.

Jirou turned to him.

“Ok. So we can’t use the front door, can we?”, Jirou asked, giving him and Katsuki a serious look.

It was too risky to try the front door, especially now that they had almost been spotted and there was someone actively looking for them. Which meant they would have to follow Deku’s shitty plan – a plan which Katsuki hated, but would have to accept under the current circumstances.

“We can use the second-floor window”, Deku vocalized his thoughts, turning to Whatshisname. “Lower you and Kaminari-kun down so you can escape through the back”.

“Hey, hold up –“, Kaminari protested.

“Ok, but how?”, Jirou frowned, completely ignoring the electric boy.

“I don’t fucking know, Ears, maybe we can make a makeshift rope using our shirts –“

“Uh”, Whatshisname stepped in as well. “Maybe I can help with that”.

Katsuki narrowed his eyes at him. Then he remembered.

“That villain back there said you have a size quirk”, Katsuki recalled.

Whatshisname frowned.

“How did he –“

“He could smell it”, Izuku provided, waving a dismissive hand. “He knew what all of our quirks were”.

“What the –“, Jirou frowned.

“Doesn’t matter”, Katsuki interrupted, urgent. “What can you do with your quirk?”, he turned back to Whatshisname.

The guy swallowed dry, eyes darting between the faces surrounding him and seeming embarrassed by all the sudden attention.

“Uh, I wouldn’t call it exactly a *size* quirk, though it could be described like that, if you put it that way. I kind of always thought of it more as an elasticity quirk, and my mom deals with a lot of heroes in training and she’s used the term elasticity, so I’m assuming –“

“Can you get to the fucking point?”, Katsuki complained, huffing out an impatient breath and gesturing at him with both hands together.

Whatshisname gave Katsuki an offended look.

“Oh, I’m *sorry*. It totally slipped my mind that we already wasted all of our plan-discussing time by going over your unresolved romantic tension with this guy a hundred times over instead of talking about an *actual escape plan*”, he pointed at Izuku.

“*Eeeh*?!”, Izuku screeched, eyes widening in horror.

“Whaaaaaat?”, Kaminari’s eyebrows shot up.

“Aw, man”, Jirou mourned with a sigh, lowering her head and face-palming.

“The fuck did you say?!”, Katsuki snarled, ready to jump at the guy but being held back by Deku. “You wanna fucking go, dipshit?”

“Yeah, because that will help us a lot!”, Whatshisname protested.

“Kacchan –“

“You’ve got quite a mouth for some useless loser who can’t even stand up for himself, eh? How about I take you back to that fucking deposit and leave your ass there to rot with those villains, since you don’t need my *help*?”

“That’d be very heroic of you, man, nice to know UA is training so many *competent* professionals –“

“Bakugou, just –“

“If *you’re* so fucking competent, how the hell did you get caught, huh? You haven’t told us that bit yet!”

“You didn’t ask! You didn’t even ask my damn name!”

“Because you’re an extra!”

“Bakugou!”

“Kacchan!”

“Dude –“

“Come at me!!”

“Stop it!”, Jirou stepped in front of him with authority. “Oi, Nitrobrain!”, she snapped her fingers in front of his face as Izuku struggled to hold him back. “Anger therapy! Remember? Take deep breaths!”

Katsuki snarled at her, swatting Deku’s hand away and regaining his composure. Fine, he had lost it. Sorry about it, Doctor Matsuo, but his stress levels were up the fucking roof. He didn’t know why Whatshisname’s comment made him feel so pissed, but his rage felt justified.

He knew he couldn’t allow himself to lose it, though. They needed to get the hell out of there. They didn’t even have enough time for Katsuki to think about what the guy meant by “romantic tension”, so he wouldn’t dwell on it.

There. Solved. Completely ignoring the issue was obviously the best option on that moment.

Katsuki wished they could just ditch this guy and figure it out on their own, but if the dipshit had a quirk that could enable a faster getaway route, Katsuki wouldn’t be stupid enough to bench him just out of spite, no matter how much he wanted to.

He didn’t have to act happy about it, though.

They all went silent as the tension from the fight died down. Jirou turned to look at Whatshisname with a soft, embarrassed face.

“I’m sorry”, she said. “We’ve been doing this all wrong. I mean – what’s – what’s your name?”, she asked.

The guy sighed, looking embarrassed and not meeting her eyes.

“Matsuo. I’m Hikaru Matsuo”.

Katsuki stared at him with a blank face.

Nah… It couldn’t be, right?

Matsuo was a pretty common surname. He probably wasn’t related to…

Well, fuck.

If he *was* related to Doctor Matsuo, Katsuki would have a hard time explaining to his anger-management therapist why he had angrily threatened to leave a member of her family rotting in a deposit room with a bunch of villains, but he’d cross that bridge when he came to it.

But this guy probably wasn’t related to her. *Probably.*

Like, what were even the chances?

“I’m sorry for our rudeness, Matsuo-kun”, Jirou said politely. “It’s just… We’ve been in a rush and things have been crazy”.

“Yes”, Deku said, bowing slightly. Kaminari followed his lead and bowed as well. “Forgive us, Matsuo-kun”.

“Now, it seems you’re the key to helping us sort this situation out”, Jirou continued. “Can you tell us what your quirk is?”

Hikaru looked at her.

“Uh... I can stretch”.

A pause.

“You can *stretch*?”, Katsuki gave him an unimpressed look.

“Yes, I can stretch”, the boy glared at him, defensive. “I can make any part of my body become highly elastic, like rubber. And I can stretch it”, he outstretched a hand towards the wall opposite to them.

The limb became longer and longer, until his hand reached the wall.

“*S-Sugoi*!”, Izuku said, looking impressed and excited. Katsuki offered him a glare so intense that it could have pulverized him on the spot, something about the way the nerd said the word making his stomach churn with an alien emotion.

“Thanks”, Hikaru rubbed the back of his head, awkward. “It doesn’t stretch for too long, though. It can only reach like, ten meters tops, and I can only keep it up for a couple minutes before it shrinks back to normal size. It *can* be called a size quirk, I suppose, since I can also enlarge any part of my body”, he shrugged. “But I don’t want to be a hero like you guys, so I never trained to enhance it. All I can do is basic things”.

Katsuki scoffed, whereas Deku frowned.

“Why don’t you want to be a hero? Your quirk is amazing, and it seems like it would be especially good for rescue operations and damage control! If you trained your stretching capacity you could even –“

“Can you get out of the fucking building through the second floor or not?”, Katsuki interrupted abruptly, annoyed. He pointedly avoided looking at Deku.

“I – I can. Yeah, I can”, Hikaru nodded, serious. He seemed tense, out of a sudden, as if his newfound responsibility had started to weight down on him. “I just need you guys to – uh, to watch my back – I don’t have the same training, I don’t know how to fight –“

“Sure”, Jirou nodded reassuringly. “We’ll look out for you as you go”.

“Great. Now that this is settled, can we get a fucking move on?”, Katsuki scoffed, suddenly in way more of a vocalized hurry than he had been a few moments ago.

They all turned to look at him.

Katsuki glared at them.

“*What*?”

“Bakugou”, Jirou said simply, a hidden demand in her voice.

Katsuki sighed.

“*Fine*. I wasn’t *actually* going to drag you back to the deposit and leave you there with the villains. Does that make you feel better?”, he snorted.

Hikaru simply sighed.

“He’s right. We should just – We should just go. I can’t *wait* to get out of here”.

“Why do I have to go with him?”, Kaminari questioned suddenly, finally getting the opportunity to speak. “I mean – I – I want to help you guys. Upstairs”, he added when Katsuki turned to glare at him.

Jirou glanced at Kaminari for a moment before turning back to Katsuki.

“No”, Katsuki said firmly before she even opened her mouth.

“He’s right, Bakugou”, Jirou supported him. “We could use his help”.

Katsuki took a deep breath, pinching the bridge of his nose while his other hand supported his hip. This whole day felt like some sort of final exam to his anger management therapy. A twisted test to see if it had worked, if he had learned anything about keeping his cool.

He was honestly *this* close to risking it all and losing his shit.

“Why do you keep *picking up the strays on our way*?”, he asked Jirou through gritted teeth. “Don’t you idiots realize that it’s easier for one person to sneak into a villain’s lair than four?”

“But it won’t be one person”, Kaminari frowned. “Midoriya and Jirou are already going with you, so that’s three”.

Jirou lowered her head again, sighing and giving Kaminari a subtle warning look.

“Yeah, look, Kaminari, don’t go there –“

“Great math skills, Braindead Pikachu, but that’s not because I *want* to”, Katsuki barked. “I’ve already told those idiots –“

“Kacchan –“

“I’ve already *told* them –“

“*Look*”, Jirou stopped him with a firm voice before he could start again. “I can do surveillance. Kaminari can help us if we need to turn something electrical off. But Matsuo-kun isn’t training to be a hero”, she pointed at the boy. “Which makes him technically a civilian. *We* can help you”, she gestured at herself and Kaminari. “Matsuo-kun is the only one of us who actually needs to leave and get as far away as possible from this whole mess. One person is already enough to contact the police and the pros, Kami doesn’t need to tag along”.

“Yeah”, Kaminari nodded emphatically.

“I know more people makes it *more* risky, but it also means more backup if a fight erupts. And like it’s the case with Midoriya, we are also heroes in training and we *also* don’t want to leave our friends behind. So instead of wasting even more of our precious time with arguing, why don’t we just go, ok?”

Katsuki squinted at her as she and Kaminari rushed past him up the stairs. Hikaru hesitated before he followed them close, leaving Katsuki and Izuku behind.

They exchanged a glance.

Izuku shrugged at Katsuki, giving him an apologetic look. Katsuki scoffed.

“I’m blaming this on you”, he grumbled, grumpy, following his friends.

“What?!”

“They were pretty fucking ok with leaving until you shoved your runny nose on my business”.

“I didn’t shove my nose on anything, Kacchan. I was just being reasonable”.

“Har har”.

“I mean it. And so are they”.

Katsuki glared at him.

“You know Jirou-san’s right. She can do the surveillance, and help us if we need. So can Kaminari-kun. They can’t just leave her friends behind, either”.

Katsuki rolled his eyes as he climbed up the stairs.

“Thank you all for your shitty trust in me”.

“Kacchan”, Izuku said seriously. “You know I trust you. With my life. Quite literally, actually”.

Katsuki glared.

“Don’t fucking go there”.

“But there are other lives at stake. And we’re also competent. It isn’t just you”.

Katsuki scoffed.

“If anything, it looks like it’s you who doesn’t trust us”, Izuku pointed out, but there wasn’t malice in his tone – just a sort of melancholic resignation. He seemed to be done getting angry at Katsuki, now that they had had three big fights in a row after so many months of silence. “I wish we could go more than one level up at a time without getting into an argument”.

Katsuki was about to spit some insults at Deku when Jirou raised a hand in front of them, a serious look on her face.

“I’m picking up something”, she announced briefly, one hand on her jack and one hand on the walkie on her waist. Her face was the definition of concentration.

“*– been responding, so I sent someone there to check. Over”.*

“Roger. Let me know if something’s wrong. Over”.

“How’s it going upstairs? Over”.

“According to the plan. Boss says it will still take a while. No sign of the kid yet? Over”.

“Nope. There’s a chance he got out, though. Boss said he’s impatient and explosive, I don’t even know why he showed up to this thing in the first place. Maybe he just… left, you know.

Over”.

Jirou raised her eyes to look at Katsuki.

“He wants to be sure. Keep telling the others to patrol the building until we know for sure this kid didn’t leave early. Over”.

“Sure thing. Over”.

“Everything ok with the plan B? Over”.

“… Will we need it? Over”.

“Boss wants to know, man. Over”.

“Yeah. It’s being brought up right now. I’m just not looking forward to needing it. Over”.

“Huh, me neither. Stay put, then. Out”.

She waited for a few seconds before she let go of the walkie, her jack still attached to it.

“They’re looking for Bakugou”, she told the group, her voice low. “They think he might have left, but they want to make sure”.

“That’s good, right?”, Kaminari whispered. “If they think he’s already left, they won’t be securing the exit points so hard”.

“*Or* they’ll be doubling security in case he’s still in the building”, Jirou pointed out. “We need to move quick if we want to get out. They were sending someone to check the deposit. But Bakugou –“, she looked at her friend, a somber look on her face.

“What?”, he frowned when she didn’t continue.

She turned so that she could face him properly.

“I’m worried about your safety. I think you should go with Matsuo-kun”, she said.

Katsuki snorted out an ugly laugh.

“Good one, Ears”.

“They know who you are”, Jirou pointed out, stern. “They know about you. You’re *clearly* a target”.

“Another reason I should stay”, Katsuki argued simply. “It’s better if they’re busy looking for me, chasing their own tails. This way, they won’t be busy trying to stop this dipshit from running out, or taking it out on our friends. Also, if they got a problem with me, they can say it to my face”.

“Like the League of Villains did?”, Jirou retorted, serious.

Izuku flinched.

Katsuki glared at her. The atmosphere became even more tense.

“I don’t want that to happen again”, Jirou continued. “So *please,* just –” she trailed off, frustrated.

Katsuki’s heart started beating a bit faster inside his chest.

Why was I the one who ended All Might?

Focus. *Focus*. He wouldn’t mess up again.

“If I go”, Katsuki pointed out, swallowing dry. “Deku will stay here”.

They all turned to look at Izuku, who blushed.

“He’ll be with us”, Jirou said.

“That’s not enough”, Katsuki didn’t miss a beat. Jirou looked offended – rightfully so.

“*Excuse* me?”

“I said what I said. The only reason we agreed to let him stay instead of sending him the fuck away from here was because I would get to keep an eye on him”.

“What?”, Izuku frowned.

“But if I go, he’ll stay anyway”, he continued.

Jirou sighed.

“Bakugou –“

“You will”, Katsuki said, turning around and addressing Izuku. “We both know you will. Because our friends are up there, and you can’t leave without them”.

Izuku’s lips closed, forming a thin, stern line. He looked serious and determined, but he didn’t say a word. And that was enough of an answer.

Yeah, Katsuki got it. He really did. Their argument back at the deposit seemed fucking ridiculous, now.

Deku couldn’t leave for the same reason *he* couldn’t leave. Katsuki knew that if he was the one with a concussion, he’d insist on staying, as long as there were villains to be beaten and people to be rescued.

Katsuki turned back to Jirou.

“I can’t, either. Especially –“, he paused, an angry look on his face. “Especially if this whole shit is happening because of *me*”.

Again.

Izuku frowned, but Jirou shook her head.

“It didn’t sound like it”, she commented. “It just sounded like they knew you could ruin things for them. I mean, it’s not weird that they know you. You won the Sports Festival *and* you were kidnapped not too long after that. I just –“, she bit her lower lip. “I’m worried”.

“You think I’m not?”, Katsuki scoffed.

“Bakugou, I *know* you are; I’m just saying –“

“Kirishima is up there. So is Mina, and Sero, and all of those assholes who like to orbit me. So is Ponytail”, Katsuki gave Jirou a pointed look. “So are the *villains.* I’m not leaving while they’re still here. For the same reason you’re not leaving”, he nodded at Jirou and Kaminari. “I’m not a coward. *We’re* not cowards”.

Jirou looked conflicted.

“I know”, she said, shaking her head slightly. Suddenly, her stern façade crumbled – and she let Katsuki see that she was more scared than he ever remembered seeing her. “But we don’t know if they’re with the League and I don’t want you to risk –“

“So what if they are, Ears?”, Katsuki interrupted her, annoyed. “Like you insist so much on saying, we’re training to be fucking heroes. We don’t get to pick our enemies. If none of you are leaving, neither am I. And fuck you for trying to make me”.

She bit her lip again, frowning.

“I know”, she said through gritted teeth. “I know that, I’m just – I’m just –“, she struggled to let the words out, tears pooling in the corners of her eyes. She didn’t let them flow.

“Jirou –“, Kaminari attempted to comfort her, placing a hand on her shoulder and seeming surprised to see her react like that.

“I don’t want you to get hurt again, Bakugou”, Jirou admitted, concern flooding her tone. “Or Midoriya. Or any of our friends”.

Katsuki took a step closer to her, stoic.

“Me neither”, he said.

“First, there was the kidnapping, then, there was the sewers… I – I thought you were dead, back then! You were bleeding and it took All Might to get a word out of you… And now… I didn’t realize how *fixated* they are on you until I heard them say it, Bakugou, and if you go –“

“I’ll beat their ass”.

Jirou sighed, deflating, as she realized she was fighting a lost battle.

“There’s just no *reasoning* with you, is it?!”, she exclaimed, frustrated.

“Ears”, Bakugou said simply, placing a hand on her free shoulder. “Look at me”.

Her moist, concerned eyes met his stern, impassive ones.

“I’ll win”, he said simply.

She continued to stare at him.

“Remember the Sports Festival? When everyone shat on me because I promised I’d win as the opening speech?”

She snorted out a humorless laugh.

“How could I forget”.

“Yeah. I’m making the same promise now. I’ll win”.

She lowered her head.

“I think I’m just… scared”, she admitted, embarrassed. “This was supposed to be a fun hangout event. Not… Not this”, she shook her head with a sigh.

Katsuki nodded. He understood the feeling.

“I know. But we rarely get what we’re supposed to get when it comes to fun hangouts. So get your shit together, Earphone Jack”, he ordered, the mention of her hero name – and the fact that he remembered it – making Jirou raise her head to look at him. “I’m going up, I’m kicking some ass, and there’s nothing you can do to stop me”.

Jirou sighed.

“I should know better than to try and put some sense into you more than once a day”, Jirou sighed tiredly. “Just – let’s all agree to be careful, ok?”

“I’ve made enough promises for today”, Katsuki said simply.

A pregnant pause.

“So, what else did those assholes say?”, he added before any of them could protest.

Jirou rubbed at one of her eyes.

“They said everything is going according to plan, but it will take a while to be over. One of the villains also mentioned a plan B, but neither of them seemed too eager about it”.

“A plan B…?”, Izuku frowned.

“So they’re already in motion up there”, Katsuki said, cursing when Jirou nodded.

“We wasted too much time on in-fighting”, Izuku pointed out seriously. “We need to make up for it”.

“For once, I agree with shitty Deku”, Katsuki nodded. “Let’s just go already”.

They all set into motion again, Izuku taking a hand to his chin and muttering to himself with a concentrated look on his face as he climbed up the stairs. Katsuki glared at him.

“Speak up, you damn nerd”, he reprimanded, rolling his eyes. Izuku gave him an apologetic look.

“If their plan is already in motion and working out well”, Izuku explained. “The villains’ guard must be down. They’re still looking for you, but they won’t expect you to be at the most obvious place, which would be the auditorium. Which means –“

“We can take them by surprise”, Katsuki nodded.

“And take them down while you call for help”, Izuku added, looking at Hikaru.

“Ok”, Hikaru nodded. “I’ll be as quick as I can”.

“Good. Thank you, Matsuo-kun”, Izuku nodded.

“Let’s just hope this works”, Kaminari commented. “I *really* don’t want to fry my brains in a fight after I got grabbed by that guy. Man, that drug quirk *sucks*”.

“Oh, that reminds me”, Deku said, rushing up a few steps so that he would be side-to-side with Hikaru. “How did you get captured, Matsuo-kun?”

Hikaru blushed.

“I got lost on the third floor on my way to the auditorium. I thought the freight elevator was the one for guests. When the doors opened, I saw a huge guy carrying her”, he nodded at Jirou. “And she was unconscious. But, before I could do anything, my vision went black, and when I woke up, I was already down at the deposit with you guys”.

“Hmm, I see”, Deku nodded. “That explains why I didn’t see you with Jirou-san. You were captured after I saw her in the elevator”.

“What about you, Dunce Face?”, Katsuki asked, trying to diverge the attention from Hikaru. “The fuck did you think you were doing?”

Kaminari didn’t look at any of them when he responded, cheeks pink.

“I noticed Jirou – and, and you – were gone for a while. Midoriya too. So just as they were about to start the speech, I snuck out”.

“*How*?”, Katsuki asked. “Because they were locking the damn place up when I left. I had to shit talk a security guard, which is why they’re still looking for me, by the way”.

“Uh… I… Might have… Used my quirk?”, Kaminari shrugged, clearly embarrassed. Upon Jirou’s curious look, he continued: “They were only guarding the front door. I sent a short voltage to the sound equipment – nothing enough to make permanent damage or anything – and took the distraction it caused to sneak out through the back. It was easier, since I was sitting in the front row. But then two guys saw me when I got to the 10th floor”.

Jirou quirked an impressed eyebrow at him, but her reaction didn’t last long.

“This is it”, Deku announced.

They all turned to look up at the boy. He was standing in front of the exit door of the emergency stairs – the one that led to the second floor.

They collectively looked at Katsuki.

Ignoring them, he climbed up the rest of the stairs and looked only at Deku.

“After he leaves – there’s no going back”, he warned, his face bearing its usual grumpy look.

Deku nodded.

“I know”.

“It’s your last chance at escape, Deku”.

“It’s your last chance, too, Kacchan”, he responded firmly.

Silence. They stared at each other.

“Fine”, Katsuki sighed. He turned to face Hikaru. “You know what you gotta do?”

“Go down. Run away. Call the cops as soon as my phone service is back and tell them what’s going on here. Tell them to call the pros”.

“Yeah. And can you do it?”

Hikaru swallowed dry.

“Yeah. I can do it”.

“All right”, Katsuki nodded. “Let’s go”.

“Wait”, Jirou stopped them before Katsuki could open the door. “I have an idea”.

She grabbed the walkie and turned to Kaminari.

“When I give you the thumbs-up, you say this: ‘Think I saw them heading to the front exit on the first floor. Chasing them now’”.

Kaminari frowned.

“What?”

“Just do as I say. That’ll create a distraction in case there’s anyone on the back of the first floor. They’ll head to the front, and won’t notice Matsuo-kun sneaking out the back”.

“But what do we do when they realize it’s a lie?”, Kaminari frowned. “Won’t that blow our cover?”

Jirou shifted her weight from one foot to another.

“Look. We’ve been on these emergency stairs for a while now and I can’t say we’ve been exactly discreet, even if *most* of us have been trying to keep the fights at a whispering-level”, Jirou commented, pointing Katsuki with a disapproving look. She turned back to Kaminari. “If they haven’t sent someone to check the stairs yet, they’re either pretty stupid or they’re certain Bakugou must be hiding somewhere else. Maybe on another auditorium, or in one of the expo rooms, I don’t know”.

“They all looked pretty young”, Katsuki commented, serious. “The villains I took down. One of them said he was going to be a hero before this”.

Izuku looked at him, realization dawning on his face.

“I think these guys are just a bunch of fucking students”, Katsuki scoffed. “Amateurs”, he added with a shrug. “Maybe the building is too big for their creepy little niche cult to cover on their own. It’s eleven fucking stairs, after all, and most of them seem to be focused on what’s happening up there”.

Jirou bit her lip again, a somber look on her face. She turned to Kaminari again.

“That’s even better for us. By the time they realize we’ve lied, by the time they even realize it was *us* on the radio, we’ll already be upstairs. And no one will expect us to be inside the auditorium, so no one will look for us there”.

Kaminari nodded, a surprised look on his face.

“Ooooh. That’s clever”.

“Yeah, I know”, Jirou smiled slightly. “Just wait for my signal, ok? Press here and say what I told you to say when I give you the thumbs up”, she pointed at a button, handing the walkie over to Kaminari.

“Sure thing, chief”, Kaminari mock-saluted her.

She rolled her eyes and approached Katsuki and Hikaru.

“Ok. You guys ready?”

“Yeah”, Katsuki nodded. “Let’s just do this already”.

Jirou walked past them, sticking her free jack through the tiny space beneath the door to listen for possible incoming. When she found none, she nodded at them, and Katsuki pushed the door open.

Deku stepped out first, looking around, before nodding at Katsuki.

Lucky for them, the back window was located at the same corridor as the emergency stairs, which meant they didn't have to go too far to sneak Hikaru out. As soon as Deku gave them the ok, Hikaru nodded his goodbye at Jirou and Kaminari before sneaking out of the emergency stairs. Deku held the door for him, and Katsuki led him to the window, covering his back.

"All right", Bakugou said once they approached the window frame. He stuck his head out carefully, looking up and down and then to the sides. He didn't see anyone, and looked back at Hikaru. "As soon as you hit the ground, run. I'll keep an eye out for you from here, but Ears' distraction should do the trick".

"Ok", Hikaru nodded, but Bakugou could see how bad his hands were shaking.

"Oi", he called the boy's attention. "Can you do this or what?"

Hikaru nodded hesitantly, breathing hard.

"I – I can do this".

"That doesn't sound so sure to me. There's hundreds of people counting on you right now, if you're not up for it –"

"I can do this", Hikaru repeated more firmly. "I'm just – I'm –"

Katsuki snorted.

"Losing your shit?"

"Kind of", Hikaru agreed with no shame, his breaths coming out fast. "I just – I don't have your training, man".

Katsuki clicked his tongue.

"You don't need my training to run away and make a call. I'll be watching your back. Do I look like the kind of person who'd let these shitty amateur villains capture your ass?"

Hikaru hesitated, which only aggravated Katsuki.

"Look here you little –"

"Fine, fine. I trust you, I trust you", Hikaru interrupted him before he could continue, raising two defensive hands. "I'll go".

“Damn right. When you call the police, tell them to tell the pros that Class 1-A from UA is here, ok? Including Katsuki Bakugou and Izuku Midoriya. They’ll know that shit is real. Oh, and here”, he grabbed his phone, digging a number up. He showed it to Hikaru, who put the number in his own phone. “That’s Shouta Aizawa’s number. You call him and you tell him the same thing you tell the police”, he instructed.

Hikaru nodded solemnly, putting his phone away and throwing one leg out the window frame. Katsuki turned to the emergency stairs, where Jirou and Deku were watching them from a small gap between the door and the doorframe.

He gave her a thumbs up. She nodded and turned to give Kaminari the same signal.

Hikaru’s legs started stretching in size, growing longer and longer until they reached the floor from the second level of the building. He made sure his legs were spread so that they grew around the first-floor window, instead of in front of them, lest anyone downstairs see them. Once his feet touched the grass of the backyard, he looked up at Katsuki, his upper body still at the same eye-level as him.

“Ok”, he nodded. “Ok, that’s it”.

Katsuki nodded back.

“I’ll watch your back. Just – make it quick”.

Hikaru nodded fast.

“Oh, and Matsuo”, Katsuki called before the boy shrunk his legs back.

Hikaru looked at him.

“Does anyone in your family happen to be a therapist?”

Hikaru frowned.

“Y-Yeah, my mom. She deals with anger management. Why?”

Katsuki closed his eyes and sighed.

“*Fuck*”.

Yeah. His next session would be fucking awkward.

“Why?!”

“Nothing. Just go, dipshit”, Katsuki said simply, waving a dismissive hand at the boy.

Without further ado, Hikaru shrunk himself down to ground level, and as soon as he was back to his normal height, he wasted no time in running for his life across the backyard of the museum building.

Katsuki watched him go with attention, ready to jump into action if needed, but it seemed no one saw Hikaru go – and as soon as he disappeared from view, Katsuki rushed back to the emergency stairs just in time to miss two villains who walked by on the parallel corridor, unaware of the students' presence just a few feet away.

As they had predicted, the 11th floor was where the action was happening.

Jirou's mouth had become a thin line of displeasure as she listened to the hall outside the emergency stairs. Since that was the floor where the villains' plan was in course, it was also the busiest one – and she kept shaking her head every time Katsuki asked her, as silently as he could, if they were clear to make a move already.

Luckily for them, the place where they needed to go – the back entrance of the main auditorium – was on the same hall as the emergency stairs. They wouldn't have to check any intersections this time.

Not so luckily, there seemed to be a lot of villains threading on the main hall, and some of them wandered off to the back one, which meant the group of friends couldn't really leave without being spotted.

Katsuki kept checking his clock. The "speech" had started half an hour ago. The villains had said the plan was in motion, but it would still be a while until it was completed. Katsuki had a hunch the plan would be completed at the same time the speech was supposed to end, which meant they only had another half hour to stall the villains and wait for the pros.

Surely, they could just hide out in the stairs and wait for the pros there, since Hikaru was already on his way to get help. But Katsuki knew, deep down in his gut, that whatever shitty plan these villains were up to couldn't be any good. And his friends were stuck in the auditorium, and the villains had said that "everything was going according to plan".

He knew that if he had the power to intervene but didn't, and if something bad happened, that would be on him. And he didn't want to carry that weight (on the top of everything else).

So when Jirou shook her head no for what felt like the hundredth time, Katsuki suppressed the urge to punch the nearest wall as loudly as he could.

He wanted to ask Kaminari to just step outside and shock every villain there into oblivion, but he knew he couldn't make such a demand. Kaminari was a student like him, and while they had their provisional licenses, they didn't have permanent ones. They weren't allowed to engage in combat with a villain unless they were being supervised by a pro.

Katsuki was pretty sure that this was an abnormal situation and that Kaminari wouldn't really get in too much trouble for helping save hundreds of lives from crazy villains. But he was also hyper-aware of the fact that he was walking on a thin line, and that any association with a case of inappropriate quirk use, even if Kaminari was the one to do it, could mean the end of his career before it even began.

It was one thing for students to use quirks under an official internship. It was *one* thing for students to use quirks when they were out on a training session and a villain who could steal souls attacked them – and that had already been Katsuki's strike one.

It was an entirely different thing to purposefully go after a villain in a sewer and blow them half to death, so Katsuki had learned his lesson.

At least now he knew better than to just *assume* what situation demanded his unofficial quirk-use, and the last thing he wanted was to get expelled from UA after everything he went through because he was too impatient. Wasn't that the alleged purpose of his damn anger therapy? Help him control this sort of shit? So there, he wouldn't be impatient. He wouldn't rush into things and screw things up because he couldn't wait a few minutes. Happy now, Doctor Matsuo?

But when Jirou's eyes widened in terror and she turned to look at him with a pale face, Katsuki knew he was about to be forced into reconsidering all that, despite his self-preservation instincts.

"What's wrong?", Deku asked, frowning in concern. Jirou's eyes darted across the stairs before she retrieved her jack.

"I – I –", she stuttered, frowning. "I've been hearing a noise, I thought it was just interference or something, but – but –"

"What is it?", Katsuki urged her.

She met his eyes.

"I think they planted a bomb".

Katsuki blinked at her.

"Oh shit", Kaminari was the first to react. "Oh shit, oh crap, oh man".

"There's this rhythmic ticking that's been going on for a while, I couldn't really catch that when we were downstairs because of the distance, but now that we're up here I – I've been thinking it was just, I don't know, something interfering, some radio signal, but now they downright mentioned a *bomb* over the radio and the plan B and…", she trailed off, a helpless look on her face.

"*That's* the plan B?!", Deku exclaimed.

Kaminari stood up and looked at Katsuki.

“Do something!”, he ordered, exasperated.

“*What*?”, Katsuki squinted at him.

“You’re the explosion guy, you should – you should –“

“I *create* explosions, you fucking moron, I don’t absorb them”, Katsuki spat. “What makes you think I know how to disarm a fucking *bomb*?”

“Guys…“, Jirou tried.

“If anything, you should do it!”, Katsuki continued. “Just shock the bomb until it short-circuits!”

“What if I blow us all up?!”, Kaminari wailed.

“That won’t be my fault!”

“Guys!”, Deku said stepped in to support Jirou. All eyes set on him. “No one’s exploding anything. Jirou-san, can you tell where the bomb is?”, he turned to her, trying to keep a calm face.

“It… It’s definitely on this floor”, she provided. “I hate to say this, but I think… I mean, there’s a high chance it’s inside the auditorium”.

They all went really silent.

“Ok”, Katsuki said pointedly. “No one shocks the fucking bomb”.

“*Thank you*”, Kaminari sighed, sagging against the step the had been sitting on.

“But what do we do about it?”, Deku insisted. “You said *this* was the plan B?”, he asked again.

“Yes”, Jirou nodded. “They were talking about how they didn’t want plan B to happen because ‘bombs suck’. I just connected the dots”.

Katsuki sighed.

“So if we burst into that auditorium, and if we ruin their main plan, they’ll use the bomb as an alternative and set it off”, he stated.

A chill fell over them, and silence stretched on. None of them confirmed Katsuki’s assumption.

“Ok”, Jirou nodded, trying to remain calm but clearly failing, if her shaking hands were any indicator. “Ok. So what do we do?”

“We can’t just wait for the pros”, Deku pointed out, looking at Katsuki. “We don’t know how long they’ll take to get here, and we can’t know for sure the villains won’t set the bomb off as

soon as they burst in".

"So what are you suggesting?", Jirou frowned.

"We should sneak in anyway and try to stop the bomb", Katsuki provided, not waiting for Deku to answer.

They all looked at him.

"Look, these are our options:", Katsuki continued. "One. We stay here and hide until the pros arrive. The villains will probably set the bomb off as soon as they get here, and then we all die. That means we're idiots for not leaving with Stretch Guy, because in the end we just hid like cowards instead of at least trying to do something. Two", he raised two fingers. "We go there and we try to turn the bomb off. Could it blow up on our faces and kill us and everyone else? *Yes*, but that's just a less-bad version of option one, because we'll at least have tried to do something. Three", he raised another finger. "We manage to turn the bomb off, we stop the shitty villain's plan and leave them with no plan B, and no one gets hurt".

Deku nodded in agreement. Jirou and Kaminari looked uncertain.

"I agree with Kacchan", Deku shrugged. "Option three is the best option".

"Ok", Jirou nodded patiently, as if she was arguing with a child. "But tell me *how* we are supposed to figure out how to disarm a goddamn *bomb* with no internet signal to google it an no previous knowledge on the matter".

"You *could* use your sound quirk to manipulate molecular frequency and dismantle it from the inside out", a foreign voice spoke from behind them. "Too bad you've just been caught".

They all turned around at the same time. Before any of them could do anything, the man grabbed Katsuki's and Izuku's shoulders.

Every single muscle in Katsuki's body went rigid and he fell to the floor, miraculously collapsing on his back. Deku wasn't so lucky, and Katsuki could spot it from the corner of his eyes that he had fallen on his face. He only hoped he hadn't hit his goddamn head again, lest he aggravate his barely recovering concussion.

Katsuki tried to turn and kick the villain, but found that he couldn't move. None of his limbs, muscles or as much as his pinky finger obeyed his commands, and he soon discovered that the only part of his body that was still moving was his chest, which was rising and falling with each of his strained breaths. He couldn't even speak – his teeth were grinded against each other, his jaw tense, and when he tried to project out a curse or a command, all he managed was a muffled grunt.

He was paralyzed.

Soon after he hit the ground, he heard two more bodies falling. Those had to be Jirou and Kaminari, and panic soon sent his breathing pattern into downright hyperventilation.

He couldn't move. He couldn't move. He was trapped.

They had been caught, and he couldn't even fight his way out. He couldn't protect Deku, or Jirou, or Kaminari like this. He couldn't even protect himself.

Deku. Oh, god, *Deku*. Katsuki tried to turn his eyes as far as they would go without moving his head, since he couldn't. All he managed to see was a vague shape of Deku, still lying on his stomach, face glued to the floor.

He tried to wriggle, he tried to escape, he tried to *move*, anything, *anything*, but he couldn't. His limbs weren't obeying him. He was fucking trapped in his own body. He grunted again, frustrated.

"Now, now, there's no use in struggling", the villain crouched beside him so that Katsuki could see him. There was a smug smile on his face, and it grew wider when he raised a walkie to Katsuki's line of sight – the one that Jirou had been keeping.

Katsuki tried to look at her, but found that he couldn't do that without moving his head – she wasn't in his direct line of sight. The only things he could see were the ceiling, the villain, and the vague shape of Deku from the farthest corner of his eye.

"There's no use in trying to talk, either", the villain continued, finger hovering above a button on the walkie. "My quirk causes a temporary paralysis of the somatic nervous system, soooo... I think you'll find it a bit difficult to move around for a while", he shrugged. "I told the guys we should have taken a look at the emergency stairs, but… They rarely listen to what I have to say. Call me annoying, for some reason. Do I seem annoying to you?", he asked, looking genuinely concerned. Then, he broke into a grin again. "Oh, wait. Never mind. You can't answer", he chuckled. "Guess I'll never know".

Katsuki groaned again, struggling and failing to move. He was breathing hard, but it was useless. The villain pressed down on the button.

"Hi, it's me. I found four of them. They were in the emergency stairs, like I so kindly suggested. I froze them, so I'll bring them over. I think the… *passion* of one of them will really help us. Over".

A few seconds ticked by, and Katsuki could do nothing other than breathe in and out. He was building up a sweat and he was fairly sure he was still be able to use his quirk and make explosions, even if his hands were paralyzed, his whole hero license thing be damned because as far as he knew this guy was about to kill them. But still, it would be for nothing. So what if he exploded this fucker up? He'd still be unable to move for fuck knows how long, and the noise would only attract other villains.

The radio response came in the form of static a few moments later.

"Great, fucking finally. Bring them in and we'll be done in half the time. Over".

The villain's smirk widened. He looked young, like the guys from downstairs had looked – he couldn't be above 20, tops. There was something about this specific villain, though, that yelled youth more than it had happened with the others – maybe it was the dimples on his

cheeks when he smiled, or the way his hair was cut, or his leather jacket, or just how carefree he seemed about everything.

This had to be a fucking student. They were being owned by fucking *senpais*.

“Copy that. Also, *you’re welcome.* Over and out”.

The villain placed the walkie on his back pocket and smirked at Katsuki again, leaning the weight of his chin on one hand.

“Ah, look at that”, he gave him a tiny, fake pout. “You’re drooling already”.

Katsuki felt a humiliated blush rise to his face.

“No need to be embarrassed, it happens to the best of us. Just let your body take over, pal. It’ll do the job for you. But if your brain hyper-fixates on swallowing, then… It’ll just make it harder for you to do it while you’re paralyzed. Just like those things when you tell a person *not* to think about the position of their tongue inside their mouth, and then they *can’t* stop thinking about it, and they *try* to move it into a new position but they keep hyper-fixating on the new position and they just spend *hours* and hours overthinking about their tongue, you know?”, he snorted out a laugh, getting back to his feet. “Hey”, he continued, looking at the direction where Jirou and Kaminari must have been. “Don’t think about the position of your tongue inside your mouth, ok?”

Katsuki groaned again, trying and failing to move. The villain laughed out loud.

“That’s even funnier because, because, since you’re paralyzed, you know, you can’t even *move* your tongue from that position”, he sighed happily. “Don’t you guys just hate me right now?”

Hell yes, Katsuki thought, grunting. He really fucking hated this guy.

The villain turned to look at him, giving him a look that was almost pitiful.

“You’re a stubborn one, heh?”, he commented half-heartedly, as if he was talking about the weather. “Guess it was you who fucked up the three guys down at the deposit?”

All Katsuki could do was glare at him. Apparently, that was enough of an answer.

“Figured. You look pretty feral, which is why I’ll take you first”.

Then, the villain simply bent down and pulled Katsuki up like a ragdoll. His body went with no resistance, and the villain threw him limply over his shoulder.

He still couldn’t move, but from this new position, Katsuki could see his three friends from a better angle. As he had figured already, Deku had fallen on his fucking face and there was a tiny pool of red liquid appearing from beneath his hidden head. Whether it was from the re-opened head injury or from a broken nose, Katsuki couldn’t tell, but the sight still made his heart beat faster.

Deku should have left. He should have fucking left, he shouldn't be here, and now Katsuki couldn't watch his back. He was helpless to protect *himself*, let alone protect Deku.

Jirou was propped against the wall, her head tilted to the side and facing away from him, her arms sprawled limply beside her. Kaminari had fallen above her, his head resting against her stomach and his legs askew. Katsuki barely managed to give them a proper look before the villain stepped out of the emergency stairs and the door closed behind them, blocking his friends from view.

The only word that could describe what he was feeling was desperation. He couldn't move, so he couldn't put up a fight. And he was actually fucking drooling, now, since the tiny automatic movements his throat was making weren't enough to handle the amount of saliva in his mouth. It was *humiliating*. His arms were flopping in rhythm with each of the villain's steps, and Katsuki absolutely hated that he couldn't do a thing about it – he couldn't even *curse*.

As they walked by the window of the 11th floor, the villain spoke up again.

"You know, you were lucky we were the ones who caught you. If an actual villain had my quirk, he'd probably be a *lot* more sadistic than I am", he chuckled again, as if sharing an inside joke with himself. "Like, he'd probably lean half of your body out the window, just to see the desperate look that would appear on your face, you know? Just half of it. Because you'd like, be totally aware that if he let go of you, gravity would take over and your body would just fall down eleven floors because you'd be helpless to hold onto anything. And on the way down, you wouldn't even be able to scream or flail around before you hit the ground".

Jesus fucking Christ, what a fucking psychopath.

"But I won't do it, so you don't have to worry, ok?", the villain told him in a mimicry of a comforting tone. "That's not what we want, not in the slightest. We're not villains, like, not even close. So you can just relax, ok? It will be good for your muscles".

He patted Katsuki's leg, and Katsuki never felt a stronger desire to blow someone's hand off.

"Take an advice from your senpai. The more you try to move while you're like this, the more your muscles will hurt when you get your movements back".

Your muscles will be the ones to hurt when I get my fucking movements back, Katsuki thought with rage. The back door to the auditorium opened, and Katsuki felt a chill run down his spine.

He could see that everyone that had been there in the auditorium when he left was sitting on the same spots, a glassy, dazed look on their faces. He managed to catch a quick glimpse of Kirishima's vacant face as he was rushed by, but he soon disappeared from his direct line of sight. He didn't even look at Katsuki's general direction, too dazed by something ahead of him.

In fact, everyone's eyes were glued on something ahead of them, something on the front of the room – but Katsuki couldn't see it without craning his head, which he couldn't currently fucking do.

"Ah, there he is. Trouble boy", the voice from the walkie-talkie greeted, and Katsuki wanted to spit on his face.

The world spun around him as he was dropped to the floor. He fell on his side, head connecting harshly with the carpet of the auditorium, and a foot pushed him into lying on his back, his arms and legs askew around him. There was a familiar sound echoing through the auditorium, a familiar voice saying familiar words like a mantra, but Katsuki was too high on adrenaline and fear to bother trying to recognize it.

Katsuki glared at the ceiling with all the intensity he could muster until a foreign face entered his field of vision.

"Hi, there. You doing ok?", the villain – probably the boss, from what it seemed – greeted.

He looked a bit older than the other villains, but still young. Possibly around 25. He did look tired, though, and therefore older. Wiser.

Katsuki wanted to fuck him up.

"Ah, all that youthful rage. I kind of miss it", the villain commented nostalgically as if he was fucking 70, crouching down beside him. "I'd ask you if you sent the fifth person we kidnapped away to get help, but…", he shrugged. "You'd be unable to answer. Also, I'm pretty sure you wouldn't tell me, even if you *could* answer".

Katsuki glared at him. The man simply sighed.

"You see, I won't take too much of your time. We're almost done here, anyway, so it doesn't really matter if he gets help. We never expected to come out of this unscathed", he shrugged again, staring off at the distance for a while before looking back at the paralyzed Katsuki. "Do you even know what we're doing here, kid? Do you know what you've gotten yourself into?", he asked, something akin to sympathy in his tone.

An amateur, disorganized, student-led hijack, Katsuki thought with disgust.

They were doing harmful villain shit, and that was all he needed to know. They had kidnapped his friends. They had made an entire auditorium hostage. They could have the best reasons and intentions in the world. They could have the most tragic backstory ever. That didn't change the fact that they were pieces of shit who thought it was ok to hurt people who got in their way to get their will done.

Plus, they had hurt Deku. Katsuki wasn't about to let that slide.

"Yeah, I figured out as much", he tapped Katsuki's leg and *oh my fucking god stop fucking touching me you pieces of trash*. "I'll wait until your friends are here before I explain, though. I hate having to repeat myself".

As if on cue, a body was suddenly dropped beside Katsuki, right into his line of sight. And his heart felt tight inside his chest as he faced Deku.

His face was completely slack, as if he was unconscious, except for his eyes, which were open and wide awake. This was like the extreme opposite of Katsuki's worst nightmare, where Deku's eyes were the dead part – now, they were the only bit of his face that showed any signs of life.

Katsuki took in how his nose looked a bit crooked and how there was blood smeared above his upper lip and down his chin. He had probably broken it when he fell on his face.

That sparkled a bitter memory in Katsuki's brain.

"So you break your damn arms all the fucking time without saying a word about it, but as soon as I try to reset your damn nose you get all whiny? How the fuck does that make sense?

"I never broke my nose before!"

"That's actually surprising".

"No! Kacchan, stop!"

"You stop, damn nerd. Just let me do this already! I can't hold you down and reset your nose at the same time!"

Katsuki wished he could move enough to at least reset Deku's nose this time, too.

(But Deku didn't even remember that first time).

His expressive green eyes were trying to tell him something, but Katsuki couldn't read them. The only thing he could tell for sure was that there was confidence in them as he stared at Katsuki, even if a single tear rolled out of it and down his temple. And Katsuki couldn't be sure if his face looked as slack as Deku's, because his jaw felt tense as fuck, but he made sure to transmit a message through his crimson eyes as well.

Stop fucking worrying. We'll be ok. I'll get us out of this. I'll win. I'll save everyone.

"Isn't this the quirkless one?", Boss Villain asked, crouching beside Deku this time.

Katsuki noticed how Deku's breathing increased its pace, and he desperately wanted to offer the boy comfort, but then the reason for Deku's reaction dawned on him.

The villain had just called Deku *quirkless* in front of their entire class.

Shit. *Shit.*

Katsuki hoped they were all too out of it to remember.

Boss Villain grabbed Deku's face by his bloodied cheeks and turned his head so Deku was facing him instead of Katsuki.

“Well, you see, that’s funny”, he commented, narrowing his eyes at Deku. “Because I remember seeing you on the Sports Festival a while ago. You’re that crazy kid who broke all his fingers”.

Katsuki’s breathing sped up and his sweating became more intense. He kept trying to move and failing.

Another dull thud came from his other side and Katsuki knew that the Paralyzer had brought in another one of his friends, but whether it was Jirou or Kaminari, he couldn’t say. He *couldn’t turn his fucking head to look*, which was driving him insane.

Why couldn’t the weak asshole just drag them all in at the same time? A concussed Deku had managed to carry three people simultaneously, for fuck’s sake.

Boss Villain let go of Deku’s face, standing up again.

“But, again”, he commented. “We now live in a world where being born with a quirk doesn’t guarantee you’ll get to die with one”, he chuckled.

What the fuck is he talking about?

Katsuki wished he could scan Deku’s eyes for answers, but since the villain had turned the boy’s head, he could no longer turn it back towards Katsuki on his own. All Katsuki could see was the crimson painting Deku’s pale skin and the tears rolling steadily down his temples and into his green hair. Whether they were tears of anger, frustration, fear, or sadness, Katsuki couldn’t tell.

He was also feeling pretty much all of those things. Anger, for being caught. Frustration, for being unable to defend himself or his friends when they needed him the most. Fear for Deku’s secret. Sadness for… For…

Well. He couldn’t quite figure it out.

He was trying to keep his confidence up and convince himself that he’d be able to get out of this, but it was honestly hard when none of his muscles obeyed him. He could guarantee his victory in a fight when he was in full control of his body, but being stuck like this… it was completely new territory. Something he hadn’t even considered before. It was maddening.

Another dull thud, the fourth one. Which meant all his friends were there.

“Well”, Boss Villain said, sounding resigned. “There’s one that’s still missing. What was it… the one with the size quirk, right?”

“Yeah”, someone who Katsuki couldn’t see replied. It sounded like Paralyzer.

“He probably ran away to get help”, another voice – this one foreign – pointed out. “Which is why we should hurry –“

“Hush”, Boss Villain ordered. The fact that he was so young, and didn’t seem to be so much older than the other villains, made his order sound even more obnoxious. “I said there’s no

need to hurry. We're almost done here. Why don't you give our guests a more comfortable view of the show?"

Before Katsuki knew it, someone was grabbing him again, which sent more disgusted shivers down his spine. He absolutely hated being touched by people he wasn't familiar with, but that didn't even compare to the feeling of being touched by villains while he *couldn't move*.

Someone placed him on a chair with a tall backrest to support his head up, and, finally, from this new sitting position, he could spot what his auditorium friends had looked so transfixed about.

At the front of the auditorium, projected from the floor to the roof, and from the left to the right on a wall, was an All Might video.

" – *Because I am here!*", All Might was saying, his tall, buff form carrying several bodies on his back while a fire raged on behind him. And then it dawned on Katsuki – *that* was the familiar sound he'd been hearing.

Katsuki knew that video. Hell, he'd seen it thousands of times as a kid, all thanks to Deku's obsession. But *why* the villains were displaying a hope-inspiring All Might video in the middle of an anti-All Might hijack was beyond Katsuki.

"I get it, I get it", Boss Villain said, walking behind Katsuki and patting his head as if he was a fucking dog, running his fingers through his hair. "You're confused. They were all confused at first, too. But look at them now…"

He used the hand that was caressing Katsuki to grab his hair with more strength than necessary and turn his head to the side abruptly.

His eyes found Mina, Kirishima, Sero, as well as the rest of UA on the first row of the auditorium. They all had those same transfixed looks on their faces, eyes dazed and teary as they stared up at the series of projections in front of them. Some of them seemed to be squirming and twitching on their seats, which meant they weren't paralyzed.

They were there voluntarily.

Katsuki wanted to frown, but couldn't. Were they hypnotized or something? Were they being mind-controlled? They didn't look like they wanted to be there, but they weren't getting up and leaving, either.

The villain turned Katsuki's head back so that he could stare at the projection, and then placed his hands on Katsuki's shoulders from behind like a tutor explaining a lesson to his mentee.

"You see, Bakugou-kun", the mention of his name sent *another* shiver down Katsuki's spine, goosebumps raising on his skin. "We aren't villains. All of us here were training to be heroes just a while ago, just like you".

Yeah, that's why you kidnapped a bunch of people and planted a bomb in a room with them. Pretty fucking heroic.

"And I know what you're thinking – that if we weren't villains, we wouldn't be doing this to you. To your *friends*… But that's just what the hero-based society we live in has installed into your brain, like a virus corrupting your ability to think for yourself. That good people can't do bad things to achieve good ends. That heroes and villains are two opposite, completely separate entities that don't overlap with each other sometimes. But your beloved government does all sorts of messed up things to keep the peace. Unfair arrests, brainwashing, espionage, training *child soldiers*… And no one bats an eye", he chuckled dryly, humorlessly. "Why should *we* be seen as the villains when *they* are seen as the good guys?"

A pensive pause.

"But I also happen to have just delivered a half-hour-long speech on that to your friends, and, like I said, I don't really like to repeat myself", he sighed eventually, letting go of Katsuki's shoulders with a final pat.

He walked around the four chairs leisurely, like he had all the time in the world, looking at each of their individual faces before focusing back on Katsuki.

"What you need to know is that heroes are a cancer. *Villains* are a cancer. They aren't black and white, but the idea our society has of them? The way we are induced to see them? That's going to be our end. Good and evil are illusions. Heroes and villains are illusions. Polarization is a *cancer*. And All Might – All Might is the epitome of all that".

Katsuki struggled to swallow, desperately attempting to regain any – *any* – possible movement. But he was as still as a statue, completely at the villain's mercy.

"For years, we all worshiped All Might like he was some sort of savior – like a 'symbol of peace', as we called him. And all for what? What good did that bring us, huh?"

Katsuki could almost smell the smoke coming off Deku's brain in his desperation to argue with that guy.

"I'll tell you what it brought us. It brought us fragility. It brought us dependence. It brought us *laziness*", Boss Villain scoffed. "We became so addicted to one unified symbol, so dependent on that single image of victory and heroism, that we became blind to everything wrong that was happening around us. As long as All Might was there to save the day, nothing else mattered. It didn't matter that children were being raised as disposable soldiers. It didn't matter that hero agencies were becoming nothing if a quick way to get rich. It didn't matter that most heroes nowadays care more about their paycheck than about saving lives. It didn't matter that the existence of such a great man was bound to result on the existence of an opposite dark force of a proportional greatness to challenge him, despite the innocent people who could get caught in the crossfire of the giants. You'd know about that better than anyone, huh?", the villain teased.

Flashbacks of All For One and All Might's final smash blossomed in Katsuki's brain.

“And so, because of that…”, the man resumed. “All Might has to go”.

Katsuki frowned mentally. What the hell was this guy even talking about?

“There can be no unachievably high standards if the main high standard is gone. There can be no absolute evil if there is no absolute good to juxtaposition it. All Might set the bar too high – and that makes villains with no scruples do whatever they can to defeat him. Even worse – that makes *heroes* with no scruples do whatever they can to try and surpass him. I believe you can also relate to that, can’t you, Bakugou-kun?”, he scoffed at Katsuki with disdain.

What the fuck.

“You, a feral, hateful boy who looks down on his companions”, Boss Villain accused, scowling. “An arrogant little brat who treats his hero training like it’s his God-given right. Who scoffs at rules and at tradition, who is disrespectful to those who came before him. But…”

He stopped in front of Katsuki, crouching down and looking up at his paralyzed form on the chair.

“You are also someone who doesn’t give in to the torture of villains. One who is kidnapped and comes out unscratched. One who remains true to his love for All Might and to his desire to surpass him as a hero”.

He leaned forwards, facing Katsuki’s paralyzed face eye-to-eye.

“And that sentiment is what is going to help me obliterate All Might from history, once and for all”.

Katsuki’s sweating intensified.

Why was I the one who ended All Might?

“Don’t get me wrong, I don’t hate All Might”, Boss Villain continued, getting back to his feet and walking to the stage of the auditorium in order to mess with some sort of antenna that was sitting there. The thing was huge and metallic, and Katsuki had noticed it as soon as he was placed into a sitting position, even if he didn’t understand what the hell it was doing there. “Actually, I *love* All Might. He’s one of the few people nowadays who can *actually* call themselves a hero. One of the few who cares more about rescuing than about getting paid or being famous. One of the few who still have the essence of goodness inside of them”.

The villain resumed messing with the antenna and turned back to look at Katsuki with a resigned expression.

“But… He’s also the picture of *perfectness.* All the other good people get overshadowed by his mighty presence. They don’t stand a *chance* against him. And as long as we keep trying to overcome perfectness – we’ll keep hitting our faces on an insurmountable wall, like characters in a video game. And I think you can agree with me that we could be focusing our energies on more pressing matters”.

He reached out and cradled Katsuki's face between both hands, as if he were some sort of loving parent.

"So here's what we'll do, now", Boss Villain said. He sounded actually nice and sympathetic as he held Katsuki's head, and the mixed signals sent a twist of repulse to Katsuki's stomach. "My quirk is pretty simple. For someone who hates polarities, it's even ironic", he chuckled. "But basically, what I do is… Well… Polarize and reverse emotions", he shrugged. "If you feel hatred, I turn it into adoration. If you feel love, I turn it into despise".

Katsuki glared at him as hard as he could, never giving up on his ongoing struggle to set himself free from the paralysis.

"I know, I know. You're probably thinking about why on earth I was training to be a hero. It doesn't sound like a very combative quirk, does it?", he chuckled. "But trust me when I tell you that turning love into despise and hatred can be more powerful and destructive than many, many weapons".

Katsuki knew. Katsuki *knew*.

"Funnily enough, my pal Brisko over there has an interesting, matching quirk. While I polarize emotions, he can *project* emotions. And thanks to our pals from Shie Hassaikai, we can both invert and project *a shit ton* of emotions now, all a nice result of their quirk-boosting drug. And that over there", he nodded back at the huge antenna, "is the amplifier one of your little UA support colleagues designed for today's contest. That pink haired girl surely does love to run her mouth about her 'babies' to anyone who'll listen, huh?", he chuckled, mocking.

Katsuki's blood ran cold.

"Do you see where this is going? Bakugou-kun?", Boss Villain asked gently, once again sounding like a tutor talking to a cherished student. Katsuki wondered if that fake gentle talk was how he had managed to attract so many young people into his anti-All Might cause – the guy *did* sound reasonable and wise, if Katsuki tried to look past all the batshit-crazy.

But yes. Yes, Katsuki saw where this was going, and he also absolutely hated it. Which was frankly scary, because that hate was about to be turned into love, apparently.

The villain gripped Katsuki's head more tightly between his hands, pressing it down, a smile spreading on his face.

"All those people came here for their adoration of All Might", he said, barely containing his excitedness and looking, for the first time since Katsuki arrived, like a bit of a maniac. "And their adoration will turn to despise. He'll be so scorned that people won't even want to look at his face, or think about him, or even *remember* him. He will finally be away from our lives, and we, as a society, will be able to move on, with new standards, new goals, new achievements. More people will achieve goodness, now that the epitome of goodness won't be on their way. Isn't that wonderful?"

No, you fucking psycho, it isn't, Katsuki wanted to answer. *You're so pissed about the fact that you're a failure that you want to set the bar lower? How is settling for mediocrity going to help anyone?*

"I can see it in your face that you don't get it", the villain told him sadly, with the smallest hint of disappointment in his tone. Katsuki hated himself for hating this wannabe villain's disappointment in him.

The villain let go of his head, taking a step back.

"But don't worry", he concluded. "Your passion will make up for your resentment".

And then, before Katsuki knew, there was something weird blossoming in his chest. As soon as the villain let go of him, Katsuki knew that his quirk was in action. He was molding his feelings, twisting them. Polarizing them, sending them to the opposite side of their spectrum. And Katsuki felt pissed as fuck about it, because he had spent fucking *months* going to that shitty anger therapy trying to get his feelings right, and now some fucker wanted to twist them around? Like that wouldn't be even *more* confusing?

He could see, from the corner of his eyes, that the villain was doing the same head-holding thing to Deku and the others. That was probably what he had done to the entire auditorium. Paralyzed those people, forced them to look at All Might and feel love for him – because who *couldn't* love the man who saved everyone with a smile? –, only to turn that love into something ugly. Something rageful. Something… Something…

Katsuki tried to close his eyes – tried not to look at All Might. But the villain had positioned his head in a way he couldn't help but to see him, and all he could do at the moment was move his eyeballs and blink when they got too dry. He couldn't actively close his eyes, and he couldn't ignore it – All Might's broad smile, his certainty, his strength. His resolve. His will to save people.

And Katsuki also couldn't deny it – he adored All Might.

He had always adored All Might. Ever since he was a brat, ever since he could remember. All Might had always been his image of victory. He had always been Katsuki's number one role model, even if he had strayed from his ways with his arrogance and bullying and anger. He had *always* been the one person Katsuki looked up to, and therefore, the person he wanted to become. The *hero* he wanted to become.

The hero he wanted to surpass.

And he could feel that adoration turning into something somber, turning into hatred and despise. He could feel those negative emotions irradiating off him in waves, he could feel them being projected, alongside with all of his friends' indifference, to the rest of Japan. To the rest of the world.

Why the fuck would Hatsume invent that shit? Sure, Katsuki was fairly certain that *projecting brainwashing feelings* wasn't the original purpose of this specific baby and that the villains had adapted it to meet their sinister goals or whatever, but *still*. For *fuck's* sake.

He tried to close his eyes again, but he couldn't. He couldn't move. He tried averting his eyes and looking away, but the projection was so big it covered the entirety of the wall in front of him. All he could do was sit there and watch All Might and feel love for his childhood hero. All he could do was sense, helplessly, as that love became despise. Scorn. *Indifference*.

He tried to close his eyes. He really tried, but he couldn't.

He could hear, albeit poorly, how Deku's breaths were starting to come off as wheezes from beside him. God, if Katsuki was feeling like shit – he couldn't imagine how Deku was feeling.

Katsuki didn't know anyone who loved All Might more than Deku. He didn't know anyone who could top his adoration for the man.

Deku would never forgive himself if he contributed to All Might's obliteration. If he contributed to All Might's obliteration because he *loved* him too much. And Katsuki knew that feeling first hand – the guilt for bringing his hero to an end.

So he needed to do something. He needed to beat these fucking villains, for the sake of hero history, for the sake of Japan, for the sake of All Might, and for the sake of Izuku Midoriya. He wouldn't allow himself to cause All Might's end once more, not again.

Not again.

He couldn't move. He couldn't fight. He couldn't blow the damn villains up. But there was still one thing he could do.

Because if anger management had taught him anything, was that he had a natural tendency to turn everything he felt into *rage*.

Fear, annoyance, concern, love – at the end of the day, he turned all of that into anger. He was working on that, he really was, even if he still lost his cool more often than not. But maybe now he could use that to his advantage. Maybe now he could make all those shitty experiences he had gone through count for something.

So he looked at All Might. He *really* looked. And in that face, he saw the eyes of the man who didn't tell him that Deku had lost his memories.

He saw the man who refused to see him right after Deku almost died, right after he took Deku's quirk. He saw the man who forced him to take One For All from Deku and make him quirkless again. He didn't think about All Might's reasons or about the circumstances behind that on that moment, because he didn't need to work with reason – he needed to work with raw emotion. So all he did was focus on the feeling, on the resentment, on the anger, on the rage. Fuck All Might's reasons, he had hurt Katsuki. He had hurt Deku, and Inko, and everyone. More than once, for that matter.

And the villain had said so himself. If Katsuki felt rage and hatred, his quirk would turn it into love and adoration.

He looked at All Might and hated him. Hated him for being so perfect that these shitty D-listers felt the need to kidnap everyone so they could brainwash Japan. Hated him for training with Deku more than he did with him, and for taking Deku's side every time, and for choosing Deku as his heir. He hated All Might for not defeating the Sludge Villain sooner, for making Deku have to rush to him, and for making Deku humiliate him by saving him. He hated All Might for giving a quirkless boy his quirk, he hated All Might for making Deku become a hero. For putting Deku in a path that could – and would – end up getting him killed.

He hated All Might. He saw him saving those people and he hated him. He hated him for ever being his role model. Maybe he would have turned out a kinder person if it wasn't for his desire to become All Might, and for his arrogance to realize that he could.

And he felt, with waves of relief, as that rage was inevitably turned into adoration.

Hah.

"Uh…", the other villain – Brisko, the one who projected the feelings to the antenna – said, frowning. "Something's wrong".

Boss Villain turned to him with a cautious look on his face.

"Hm?"

"Something's wrong", he repeated. "Someone's not sending off rage or despise".

A pause. Boss Villain approached him.

"What the hell do you mean?"

"Someone's sending off, uh, love? And adoration?", Brisko said, clearly confused.

A brief pause. Katsuki would smirk if he could.

"So you mean to tell me", Boss Villain said through gritted teeth. "That someone in this room suddenly decided to hate All Might?"

"Y-Yeah…?", Brisko said, sweat forming on his brow.

Boss Villain stared at him.

"Just like *that*?"

"Yeah, I don't know – I don't know how –"

"That's not possible", Boss Villain interrupted him dangerously. "People don't just decide to hate someone they love out of nowhere".

"I know, but it's happening. Should – Should I cut off the transmission…?"

“Do *not* cut off the transmission”, Boss Villain ordered, pointing a finger at the man’s face. Brisko didn’t seem too happy with that, but he didn’t say anything.

Boss Villain turned around to look at the four teens lined up in front of him, his face beginning to show the signs that he wasn’t so good at masking his anger behind collectedness. So much for polarizing other people’s emotions, huh?

“Which one of you is it?”, he demanded, his voice on the brink of becoming a shout.

None of them could reply.

He marched up to Deku, like the loser he was, assuming he’d be the most obvious answer.

“Is it you?”, he grabbed Deku’s face with one hand. “Are you angry he couldn’t stop you from losing your quirk? Is that it?”

“H-Hey –“, Brisko tried to say, but the man paid him no mind.

“Oh, that’s it, isn’t it?”, Boss Villain scoffed, grinning down at Deku. He craned his neck to look at Brisko. “Is it him?”

Brisko opened and closed his mouth.

“I – I can’t tell for sure, but – it’s – it’s coming from that direction, yeah”, he nodded.

Boss Villain pressed his hand harder into Deku’s face, making him look like a fish, before letting go of him again. There was a creepy smirk on his lips as Deku’s head lolled uselessly to the side.

“There. Now your *feelings* won’t interfere with my better society”.

Katsuki wanted to smirk again. That was *all* he needed – for the villain to stop transmitting Deku’s emotions.

Because hell yeah, he could definitely turn his feelings for All Might into hatred and anger and resentment for a few moments, but *none* of that would be useful against Deku’s outstanding adoration for the man. As long as Deku’s adoration was being turned into despise, Katsuki’s hatred being turned into love didn’t stand a *chance*.

But now that Deku’s intense love was out of the way? Hah.

Katsuki was about to fuck these villains’ plan over.

So he did what he did best, and what Doctor Matsuo had warned him so much against – what he had tried to control and suppress during all those months of therapy.

He let his anger take over all his other feelings.

Hate All Might Hate All Might Hate All Might Hate All Might Hate All Might. He didn’t get there in time to stop you from losing your hearing. He didn’t tell you or Inko that Deku was

dying. He didn't tell you that Deku didn't remember his time as a ghost. He chose Deku over you. He forced you to take Deku's quirk and make him miserable. He didn't explain your side to Deku and let him keep hating you. He ended his hero career over you. Hate All Might Hate All Might Hate All Might Hate All Might –

"It's not him", Brisko said, his voice way more fearful than before. "It's not – the – the love is getting stronger, we can't –"

"You better not turn that transmission off, Brisko. We're too close", Boss Villain warned, approaching him again.

"You don't understand – it's *overlapping.* This never happened to me before, I – The love is getting stronger than all of these people's indifference combined".

"That shouldn't be *possible*".

"Well, why don't you try to detect who this is coming from, then?!"

"What did you *say* to me?"

"Bossing me around won't help anyone, what we should do is cut the three of them off the transm–"

"You know I can't do that, once the inversion is over my emotions are disconnected from –"

A foreign sound stopped their discussion.

They both turned to look at the source of the sound, as did the two villains standing behind them – the Paralyzer and another one Katsuki didn't recognize, one who was wearing a face mask.

The sound had come from his right, from the opposite side of Deku. It sounded like… sniffing?

Boss Villain walked back towards the four chairs, staring at either Jirou or Kaminari – Katsuki couldn't be sure. He couldn't distinguish the sound, either, until –

A sob. Loud, and gut-wrenching.

It was definitely Jirou.

???

"What the hell?", Boss Villain said. "Should she be recovering already?"

Paralyzer stepped away from the stage and approached them, looking at the girl.

"My quirk wears off faster on A blood types… That could be it".

Katsuki's heart sped up. *He* was an A-type, and he had also been caught before Jirou. He had been so focused on his task of hating All Might that he had stopped trying to move, which meant…

He tried to smirk.

His lips gave off the faintest twitch.

He tried to swallow. It worked.

Slowly, he attempted to move his pinky finger. He couldn't just yet, but the smirk and the swallowing were already good signs. And the villains were too focused on Jirou to notice it.

"She still should be in a trance like the others", Boss Villain scoffed, turning to Brisko. "Is she the one who hates All Might?"

Brisko shrugged, scratched his head, and shook his head, all at the same time. Apparently, transmitting feelings was the only thing he was good at, and tracking their source was an ability forgotten along the way.

"I can't freeze her again", Paralyzer pointed out. "My quirk only works on the same person once every 24 hours".

"Then grab some ropes to tie her up before she moves", Boss Villain commanded and waved a dismissive hand at him, clearly trying to keep his cool. Paralyzer nodded and disappeared at the back of the auditorium.

"We were doing fine before", Brisko said pleadingly. "The plan was working just fine, it only started going south after we put them in. I think – I think we should just disconnect them and keep – keep going like we were doing before –"

Boss Villain sighed angrily, placing his hands on his hips.

"How long will it take to finish if we disconnect them now?", he asked, reluctant.

"Uh, the – the positive emotions set us back around half an hour –"

"Half an *hour*?", Boss Villain exclaimed.

"Y-Yeah. And it'd take, uh, around forty-five minutes for us to reach everyone in Japan again and for the effect to be permanent".

Boss Villain turned to the four of them, hatred finally evident on his face. All the fake calm from before had evaporated.

Hah. Katsuki had just made them lose half an hour of their shitty villain work because All Might had pissed him off a couple times. Losers.

He could also move all the fingers of his hands now, which was definitely a plus.

“Fine”, he gave in, marching back towards them. “I’ll disconnect them. I won’t let four brats stand in the way of a better society. Of a *right* society”.

Boss Villain approached Jirou first, since he thought she was the only one free from the paralysis – and therefore, the most likely of them to try and escape.

Katsuki took the opportunity to try and crane his neck the slightest bit to the side, still feeling as his hatred was turned to adoration and rolled off him on waves. He managed to catch a glimpse of Jirou, who was also looking at him from the corners of her eyes.

There was blood dripping from her ears – from her jacks –, which made Katsuki frown in concern. Had that happened during the capture?

No. That blood was way too fresh. His eyes widened in realization.

Her jacks looked longer than usual, as if she had overstretched them and they were struggling to shrink back to their normal size. And once he stopped focusing on her tear-covered face – because overusing a quirk always hurt like a bitch, as Katsuki could tell from first-hand experience – and finally focused on her *hands*, he finally got it.

She was subtly pointing at something. And as Katsuki followed the direction of her finger, he spotted it.

A bomb. Just a few meters away, sitting beside the stage.

Had she… had she managed to disarm it? By altering the frequency and dismantling it from the inside out, like the Paralyzer had suggested?

Had she fucking overstretched her jacks so she could disarm the bomb with no one noticing it?

Holy shit. Holy *shit*.

Katsuki flexed his fingers. He could also move his toes now. Just a few seconds more, and he’d be able to get out of that damn chair.

Jirou was still looking at him as Boss Villain grabbed her face, pressing on it and undoing his quirk. Katsuki winked at her, showing that she wasn’t the only one regaining her movements.

Upon this, Jirou averted her eyes towards the villain and sobbed even louder.

“I – I –“, she stuttered. Katsuki figured she was pretending to still be partially paralyzed – he could already move pretty damn well, which meant so could she.

“What? Is it *you*?”, Boss Villain asked.

“I want to say – I – I –“, she continued, keeping up with the frail girl act. Boss Villain seemed annoyed.

“Speak up, kid”, he ordered, letting go of her face and standing up straighter in front of her.

A pause.

“I just want to say I disarmed your *bomb*, idiot”, Jirou said, perfectly coherent.

Then she jammed both her jacks into the Boss Villain’s sides and shocked him as hard as she could, kicking him away from her.

Everything happened at once.

Both Boss Villain and Jirou screamed – him, from the pain of being shocked, and her, for the pain of using her sore, overworked jacks. Katsuki wasted no time into getting his ass up at once and grabbing both Deku and Kaminari, who were still paralyzed. He didn’t know their blood types, but he was fairly sure they weren’t A, otherwise they’d be up already.

His body was still way too stiff and his muscles were sore, one of his legs dragging limply on the floor as he tried to rush away and carry them both at the same time. But he could move, mostly. That would have to be enough.

He threw Deku and Kaminari to the floor a bit too harshly because of those circumstances. Once he made sure they were out of harm’s way, Katsuki turned back and launched himself at Brisko, his leg still stiff but getting some of its movement back.

The man yelped and turned to run away when he spotted Katsuki plunging towards him like a feral animal. But Katsuki, even limping, was faster. He took the guy out with a single punch, making him fall boneless to the floor.

The truth was: neither him nor the Boss Villain had combative quirks, which meant Katsuki and Jirou wouldn’t actually need to break the law and use their powers to knock them out. All they had to do was use their fists – which was less illegal.

Katsuki then kicked the projector to the floor, breaking it, and disconnected the sound equipment next to it with a harsh yank of the wires. Suddenly, all evidences of All Might disappeared from the auditorium – no more images and no more sounds.

People started to blink, awakening from their haze. It seemed that knocking Brisko out was also helping that. Maybe a side-effect of his transmission quirk was hypnotizing people, but Katsuki didn’t have the time to speculate.

He turned back to the Boss Villain, who was currently fighting Jirou. He seemed dazed by her jacks, but was also skillfully blocking her kicks and punches with his arms. Just as Katsuki rushed to her aid, forgetting all about the villain in the face mask that was still free but just standing there, Boss Villain managed to grab the girl by the neck, holding her up with her feet dangling just above the floor.

“Oi, fuck face”, Katsuki called, his hands popping. He couldn’t use his quirk to kill the man, but he sure as fuck could use it to propel himself against him.

Boss Villain let go of Jirou, who fell to her knees, coughing. Around them, in the auditorium, the people who seemed to be regaining their senses were starting to stand up. Some of them

were already running out in fear.

“You’re naïve and *stupid*”, Boss Villain said, focusing his attention on Katsuki. “Who do you think you’re helping, huh? Who do you think you’re saving?”, he took a step closer to him. “You’re just playing their game. You’re just a little pawn for them. You’re just helping the very system that oppresses you!”

“Bakugou”, Jirou warned him, her voice raspy as she clutched her sore throat with one hand. “Behind you”, she nodded.

Katsuki turned slightly to look. The villain in the face mask was staring at him from the distance, analyzing him. Reading him. But he still hadn’t moved from his spot on the top of the stage, just standing there, frozen.

Katsuki hated it.

“I’ll deal with you in a moment”, he promised him. “Let me just kick your boss’s ass, first. Jirou, get everyone out”, he instructed without looking at her. “Get Deku”.

“I’ll take Midoriya”, a voice announced. Katsuki turned to look, finding the goddamn Half’n’Half bastard gazing back at him with those cold, multicolored eyes of his. “Unless you need a hand”, he offered with a stoic face.

Katsuki scoffed.

“Fuck off, Icy Hot”, he barked, but there was the hint of a smirk appearing on his lips. “As if I ever needed your damn help”.

“Suit yourself”, Todoroki said simply, calmly, walking past Jirou.

The smirk died on Katsuki’s lips when he saw Half’n’Half cradle Deku’s limp form to his chest bridal-style, tucking his head against his neck and adjusting one of his arms around his shoulders. Deku’s face was still vacant and his eyes were still open, darting around madly since they were the only things he could move on that moment.

The blood on his face, albeit dry, left an ugly brownish mark on Todoroki’s perfectly white turtleneck shirt, ruining it for good.

“I’ll take Kami, then”, Jirou provided, rushing to Kaminari’s side. Some people at the auditorium were getting up and leaving on their own, but some of them were still staring fixedly at the wall where the projections of All Might had been. Todoroki waited until Jirou had adjusted Kaminari on her back, giving him a piggyback ride, before they both rushed out together.

“What makes you think I’m their boss?”, Boss Villain scoffed in a disdain that was disguised as pity, clearly pissed off to have his plans ruined like that and trying to sound superior.

Katsuki turned his attention back to him.

“You’re the one throwing orders around, jackass”, he snorted.

“There are no bosses here”, he shook his head, sounding almost offended. “We are all equals in our desire to eradicate All Might –“

“ – For a better society, yeah, yeah, yeah. You’ve already said all that. Weren’t you the loser who hated repeating himself?”

The villain growled, annoyed.

“There will be no place in my society for people like you”.

“There will be no ‘your society’. Period”, he scoffed.

“People who think they are superior to others. People who act like bullies and get praised for it. People who undermine the value of other lives”.

“Yeah, that’s no longer me, dipshit”, Katsuki scoffed. “I’ve been going to therapy. Also, I’m done talking”, he announced, jumping at the man. He managed to land a kick, but Boss Villain rolled on the ground and got back to his feet quickly.

“No longer you?”, he villain chuckled. “Look at yourself, kid. Look at the way you talk in a fight. Look at the way you act. You have no respect”, he tried to punch Katsuki, but he rapidly dodged the blow, grabbing Boss Villain’s arm and slamming him to the ground back-first.

The villain panted up at him, defeated. He probably knew he was no match for Katsuki from the beginning. He didn’t look like the kind of guy who did a lot of combat training, whereas Katsuki trained with fucking All Might himself.

“My respect is only for those who earn it”, Katsuki snarled down at him, still holding his arm. “It’s for All Might, and for my senseis, and even for my parents, when I feel up to it. I ain’t about to bow my head and pretend to reverence someone who kidnaps and hurts students because of deluded, self-centered ideas”.

“And will you take pleasure in hurting me, Bakugou-kun?”, the villain smiled briefly, glaring daggers into Katsuki. “Will you enjoy it as I bleed?”, he became serious.

Katsuki tightened his grip on the villain’s arm.

“I wish to hell I could, but I won’t”, he scoffed. “Make you bleed, that is”, he clarified, twisting the villain’s arm and pushing him into lying on his side, so that he could secure his hand behind his back. “I’ll leave that to the pros”.

“Yeah, because they have a license, huh?”, Boss Villain laughed humorlessly. “So they can do whatever the hell they want to me. I’m a *villain*, so I deserve to beat up by people, as long as they’re the right people, huh? Because they have a piece of paper that tells people they are gods, so it’s fine?”

“They aren’t gods”, Katsuki spat. “They’re heroes. And arresting pieces of shits who think the world of themselves like you do is just part of their job”.

“I see”, the villain sighed, allowing his body to relax and giving in to Katsuki’s restraining hands. “I see, now”.

For some reason, that pissed Katsuki off, and he twisted the villain’s arm behind his back further, a bit too tightly. He groaned.

“You see? That’s exactly what I’m talking about”, Boss Villain scoffed. “You will be a violent hero, Bakugou-kun. A hero who causes only destruction and pain, and you’ll even get *rich* for it. And you’ll do that *convinced* that you’ll be surpassing All Might, but all you’ll ever manage to be is a bad copy, because *no one* can surpass him!”

“Yeah, and conforming myself with mediocrity is clearly the best way”, Katsuki scoffed with disdain. “You’re *pathetic*. Just because you realized your shitty quirk will never get you to the top of the charts, doesn’t mean everyone else should be as pathetic as you. And talk about how our society is fucked up and how we value the wrong things all you want – it won’t change the fact that you’re a fucking psycho who just kidnapped a bunch of people and tried to brainwash an entire country. Now *you* try to convince the court you’re the good guy with all of that evidence against you”.

Katsuki looked around, already fed up by this guy’s fucking antics. Where the fuck were the damn pros, anyway?

More and more people were rushing out of the auditorium. Mina, Kirishima and Sero were finally on their feet, along with the rest of 1-A. Kirishima and Mina were the first ones to rush to the villain in the face mask, realizing he was the only one left. They grabbed him, even though he wasn’t moving or resisting. Sero rushed to their aid, whereas the rest of 1-A started scattering around and aiding the still-dazed people out, since Katsuki had already taken care of the main threat.

“Hey, what the *fuck* –“, the Paralyzer finally returned through the back door with a bunch of ropes and duct tape to tie Jirou up, only to find half of the auditorium gone and Brisko knocked out. He tried to make a run for it, but Sero wasted no time in throwing a tape at him and wrapping him up from his feet to his neck before he could even think about paralyzing anyone or escaping. The man tripped on his own stuck feet and collided heavily with the floor.

“There will be no evidence against me, Bakugou-kun”, Boss Villain smirked, body lax and head resting on the floor, his back turned to Katsuki as the boy restrained him.

“I’m tired of hearing you talk”, Katsuki scoffed. “Sero, wrap this dipshit up”.

Sero obeyed and wrapped Boss Villain up with his tape, also from his feet to his neck. Katsuki let the stuck man go, cocooned, and got back to his feet.

“Don’t you want to know why?”, Boss Villain’s smile widened as Katsuki walked away from him.

“You good over there?”, he asked Mina and Kirishima, who were still holding the villain in the face mask. Katsuki didn’t know about the other villains who had been outside or

downstairs, but he was pretty sure they must have fled when things went south. They were definitely outnumbered now that everyone was awake and in their right minds.

Kirishima raised a thumb up at him. Sero wrapped the face-mask villain up, and they both let him fall to the floor of the stage before approaching Katsuki.

“You really don’t wanna know why?!”, the Boss Villain asked from the floor, amused.

Katsuki ignored him again. Jirou rushed back into the auditorium, panting.

“How’re your ears?”, was the first thing Katsuki asked her upon her arrival, since there was still blood running down her jacks. Mina seemed horrified at the sight, not having noticed it before.

“Jirou!”, she exclaimed, worried and reaching out for her.

“They’ll survive”, Jirou winced. Now that she was close to him, Katsuki could see how pale she looked.

“Oi, Bakugou-kun”, Boss Villain called from the floor, sounding slightly more annoyed, but he was once again ignored.

“Nice job with him”, Jirou told Bakugou, still catching her breath. “How’d you do it?”

“For all that shitty talk of training to be a hero, he seems to have skipped a few of the practical lessons”, Katsuki scoffed. “So I took him down and Sero wrapped him up”.

“A gift to the pros”, Sero clarified.

“Nice”, Jirou scoffed. “So what should we do?”

“There are still people just sitting around”, Kirishima spoke up. “It wouldn’t be manly to just leave them there. I’ll take care of that”, he nodded firmly at his friends before rushing to the closest dazed person, helping them up.

“I’m staying here until the pros arrive”, Katsuki announced. “Don’t wanna risk these douchebags running away”.

“We’ll keep you company”, Jirou nodded.

“So much for a fun day at the museum, huh”, Mina sighed with grief.

“You see, this shit is why I don’t like going out”, Katsuki huffed simply, crossing his arms above his chest.

“Yeah, man. Museums are *way* crazier than I had imagined”, Sero chuckled.

“Well, at least you got to kick some ass while you were at it, huh?”, Kirishima shrugged from the distance, already piling three people up on his shoulders.

“Meh”, Katsuki shrugged. It hadn’t felt as satisfying as he had expected, for some reason.

Maybe he just had a lot to think about.

“Fair enough”, Kirishima nodded. “I’ll see you guys downstairs, ok?”, he announced, rushing out with the remaining people.

Now, they were the only ones left at the auditorium – Katsuki, Sero, Mina, and Jirou, as well as the three restrained villains.

The four friends looked down at the men. Then, Sero’s eyes found the broken projector on the floor, next to the face-mask villain.

“Thanks for kicking that thing, man. That was driving me insane”, Sero sighed, looking at Katsuki.

“Yes”, Mina agreed, looking serious – more serious than she usually looked. “That… That was pretty awful”.

Yeah. Speaking of pretty awful…

“How was Deku?”, Katsuki asked Jirou in a low voice, even if he knew his friends could hear him.

“He was still paralyzed when we got down there”, Jirou told him, serious. “Todoroki-kun is looking after him. He broke his nose when he fell down, but, other than that, he seemed ok, if only a bit angry that he had to leave while you’re still up here”, she gave him an apologetic look.

“Tch. Idiot”, Katsuki scoffed, avoiding her eyes. “Having him be paralyzed was probably the only way to get him out of here without him throwing a goddamn tantrum”.

“Oi, Bakugou-kun”, Boss Villain called again from the floor, growing more insistent.

“Speaking of tantrums, I wonder what happened to those guys at the deposit?”, Jirou frowned at him.

“Guys at the deposit?” Mina asked, confused.

“We have a lot of catching up to do”, Jirou gave her a sigh and a tiny, tired smile. “It’s been a long day”.

“We released them as soon as we found them, of course”, Paralyzer offered from where he was restrained on the floor. “But I’m guessing that question was rhetorical”.

“You guessed right”, Sero nodded before slapping the guy’s mouth shut with another one of his tapes. Paralyzer simply rolled his eyes and let his head fall to the floor, resigned.

Katsuki squatted down beside him with an angry look on his face.

“Just so you know”, he growled. “You *are* annoying as fuck. And a fucking psychopath, for that matter”.

All he got in return was a muffled sigh and another eyeroll.

“So you’re not gonna ask about Kaminari?”, Jirou raised a teasing eyebrow at Katsuki, who scoffed.

“I know you wouldn’t have come back up unless he was ok, so I don’t have to ask”, he teased back. The girl blushed and looked away.

“Oi, *Bakugou*-kun”, Boss Villain called again, sounding angry, and Katsuki finally lost his cool.

“If you don’t shut the hell up, I’ll knock you out”, he snapped at the man. “Then we’ll find out if I’ll find it satisfying to see you bleed”.

Boss Villain started chuckling, going right back to the brief looking-like-a-maniac look from before.

“This is so perfect”, he commented, giddy.

“Yeah, having you go to jail sounds really damn perfect to me”, Katsuki scoffed.

“Oh, I’m not going to jail. You really don’t want to know why?”, he smiled.

“No”, Katsuki snarled, but Jirou grabbed his arm, tense.

They shared a look. She seemed worried.

“Why are you not going to jail?”, she asked the man cautiously, almost fearfully.

The villain’s smile grew wider than ever – but it no longer looked manic.

It looked peaceful, like he had accomplished all of his goals.

“Because the bomb you disarmed wasn’t the only one”, he said simply. And then he snorted out another tiny chuckle, like he was trying to hold back his laughter.

Time slowed down as Katsuki’s stomach dropped.

He turned his head to look at the bomb Jirou had disarmed. It didn’t look functional.

But then his eyes found the villain in the face mask, who was wrapped up and lying on his side on the stage.

His face mask was partially gone, its remains glued to the sides of his cheeks. It looked like it had been eaten away by some sort of acid.

And now his cracked, scarred lips were on display.

He opened his mouth wide and started retching loudly, a bright orange liquid spewing out and dribbling down his chin. It looked like he was puking out magma, or maybe the acid that had destroyed his mask.

It was eating away the wooden floor of the stage.

And from the part that had already corroded away, Katsuki saw it – something Jirou couldn't have detected with her hearing quirk, because it wasn't an electronic bomb, because it didn't have a timer, because it didn't make a *sound*.

The floor beneath the stage seemed to be filled to the brim with dynamite. And there was acid pouring right on it, about to ignite it any second now.

The plan B.

Boss Villain was smiling quietly now, satisfied with himself. The Paralyzer started to wriggle madly in his desperate attempt to escape, but failed, and the acid-spitting villain simply continued to spew acid onto the explosives.

There was enough there to take out the whole damn floor.

So, whatever you're planning, give it up. This building's construction was rushed by the Estate so that the museum could open on schedule. It doesn't have a really strong foundation. If you attack us right now, you'll bring the entire structure down, along with your friends and everyone else who's upstairs.

Scratch that. There was enough to take out the whole damn *building*.

Katsuki really hoped everyone had cleared out. He hoped Kirishima had managed to get out with the rest of the people.

"And you know what's the best part?", Boss Villain continued suddenly, just at the same time Mina, Sero, and Jirou caught up with Katsuki's brain and realized what was about to happen. "You're the *explosion* boy!", he added, cheerfully.

Katsuki looked at him and saw victory on his face.

"This is even better than I first planned", Boss Villain told him. "I wonder who they'll blame for the whole building blowing up to pieces, huh? I wonder what your precious *hero society* will do for you now, after you've caused so much damage and *death*".

Katsuki swallowed dry.

"I'll stop him –", Sero tried to rush to the face-mask villain, meaning to drag him away from the stage.

"No!", Mina held him back, dragging him away. "There's no time, let's go!"

Katsuki was vaguely aware of his friends begging him to run and leave as well, as if they'd ever stand a chance of going down eleven floors of stairs before the fucking dynamite went off.

"I won, Bakugou-kun. I *won*".

Katsuki looked at his friends. Their faces were desperate and urgent and horrified, and he felt electricity run across his whole body. He could smell, from there, the stench of the other villain's corrosive bile as it spewed on top of the explosives, ready to set them off any moment now.

He turned his head and saw victory sparkling in Boss Villain's peaceful eyes.

And like hell he'd let that guy win.

Like *hell.*

Red and orange lighting sparkled around his limbs, running across his body, making the hairs of his arms stand up and electric shivers run down his spine. He felt like he was a dam about to burst, his barriers getting poorer and poorer at their one job of holding back an immense force, a massive power. He was cracking, and he knew it, and he didn't want it. He wouldn't go as far as to say he was afraid, but he didn't want it.

He didn't *want* it.

He tried to hold back, because deep down he wanted to do this on his own, he didn't want to rely on the borrowed power that was coursing through his veins and making his fingertips tingle. But it was like an instinct, really – like a primordial reaction he wouldn't know how to control, even if he tried for a million years. Like closing your eyes when you sneezed, or like kicking out when the doctor pressed down on your knee nerve.

At his core, this was who he had always longed to be, and who he had always feared he would never succeed on becoming. Because there were people who were way better than him at it, even if he would never admit it, like Deku was, if not for his sheer will power, then for the goodness of his heart.

A hero.

Katsuki couldn't hold back for much longer. The reaction – the lightning, and the surge of power, and the crack on all his walls – had started merely a split second ago, but things felt

like they were moving in slow motion. Like time had slowed down.

His actual hair was standing up from his head because of the electricity sparkling to life across his skin, his crimson eyes were glowing a bright blood-red, his jaw was locked so tight from the effort of holding back that his skull felt like it was about to snap from the tension.

The sheer struggle of trying to keep One For All at bay and prevent it from exploding out of him was taking everything he had, and shameful tears were pooling in his eyes, a strained grunt escaping from his raw throat. He snarled.

His hands were tightened into fists, and there were pops already emerging from the closed palms. Katsuki spared one strained look to his right side.

His friends, Mina and Sero and Jirou, collectively trying to drag him along and letting go in shock as his skin came to life with static.

There was no other way.

Nine silhouettes stared down at him from the back of the room, behind the villain who was lying wrapped in front of him. They were all shadowy and ominous and mysterious, but there was only two he could recognize.

Of these two, one was reaching out for him. Offering him his hand. Offering him his help.

Could he finally take that hand, after all those years?

Are you all right? Are you hurt? I was worried you might have hit your head or something –

Yes. Yes, he could.

With a harsh outtake of breath, Katsuki squeezed his eyes shut in anticipation, unable to hold back anymore. Seeing that hand only served as a reminder of *why* he had triggered One For All after all these months of never reaching for it, never daring to use it. Of pretending it wasn't even there.

If he wanted to win, he needed to save those people. His friends. If even one of them died, he would lose. The villain would win. And he couldn't let that happen.

He let the sparkles around him come to life unhinged, and he reached out for the hand.

Instead of grabbing it, Katsuki directed the wall behind the villain with a mighty explosion. Mightier than any he had ever been capable of producing.

The concrete burst into pieces with a loud crack, opening a hole on the side of the building that led directly to the world outside.

They wouldn't have the time to climb down eleven fucking levels of stairs.

He moved faster than the blink of an eye, jumping and managing to fetch his three friends into his arms at the same time. They had fallen to the floor, thrown back by the air that was

dislodged by Katsuki's explosion.

The speed One For All granted him was amazing, and using his powered-up explosions to propel himself forwards would probably make him quicker than usual – when he was moving alone. Carrying three bodies was bound to slow him down, even if just a tiny bit, and because of that they would all escape faster if he threw his friends out of the building first and then jumped after them.

The bomb was about to go off any minute now, so they didn't have any time to waste.

Jirou, Mina, and Sero squirmed and gasped in his arms, the series of events happening too fast for them to keep up. Katsuki held on tighter to them, and was ready to launch them out and jump after them when he spotted her.

A flash of pink caught in the corner of his eye. Katsuki turned his head to find Hatsume running back into the auditorium, towards her forgotten invention, and stopping on her tracks when she saw the scene unfolding before her.

She had probably been dragged out by someone after he broke the projector, too dazed to protest, and now that she had regained her senses, she had come back to save her baby. And she didn't know about the fucking bombs, because, like everyone else, she thought there was only one – the one that Jirou had disarmed.

She had thought it would be safe to come back. She had thought Katsuki had the situation under control.

Fuck.

Ok, focus. Think fast.

Katsuki mustered all his force to launch Jirou and Mina out through the hole in the wall first, as hard as he could, away from the building. The girls screamed as they flew across the air, and the sound grew more distant as they began their descent towards the cold, hard floor that waited for them 11 floors down.

"Sero!", Katsuki screamed next, his voice coming off guttural and booming. He launched Sero out right after them, trusting he'd know what to do. Trusting he'd catch the girls and catch himself and use his tapes to bring them all down to the ground in safety, in time.

Behind them, the villain continued to retch. He couldn't have been doing that for more than a few seconds – but Katsuki's perception of time was too altered for him to know for sure.

He could try to use One For All to kick the damn villain away from the bombs, but he wasn't so sure that getting his explosions and the lighting that was coursing across his skin so close to dynamite would be the wisest decision at that moment. If that thing blew on his face, there was no way he'd survive.

There was only one thing he could do, then.

He turned on his heels and launched himself towards Hatsume, who was standing at the farthest end of the auditorium, near the main entrance. Diametrically away from him and the hole that he had blown on the wall.

There was no time for her to go back down and out of the building before it exploded. There was no time for Katsuki to reach her and make it out safely with her.

Two bodies were heavier than one. When it came to propelling oneself forwards with only one hand to provide an explosion, two bodies moved *slower* than one. And he couldn't blast a huge fucking popping explosion to propel themselves out, lest he activate all the bombs in the room and kill them before they made it out.

Regarding explosions and acceleration, every millisecond mattered.

If Katsuki jumped out alone, propelled by a small explosion, his acceleration would be enough for him to escape before the bombs went off. If Hatsume jumped out alone, propelled by a small explosion, her acceleration would be enough for her to escape before the bombs went off.

If they jumped together, the weight would be doubled. One small explosion from his hand wouldn't be enough to propel them both into the right acceleration. The lag would be of milliseconds, something ridiculous and barely even noticeable in any other situation, something Katsuki didn't even think about too often because of how unnoticeable it was – but, in a scenario like this, just a millisecond too long was enough to sign their death certificates.

If Katsuki had jumped out alone, his acceleration would have been enough for him to escape.

Katsuki reached Hatsume.

The villain's acid finally achieved its purpose, and the first dynamite blew up, setting all of the others off almost immediately. Even the bomb Jirou had deactivated came back to life with a vengeance.

He only had one second before the blast struck them.

He grabbed her arm at the same time she opened her mouth to scream in fear because of the explosion. Before the sound could crawl its way out of her throat, he spun around and she spun with him.

500 milliseconds.

He looked like a crude ballet dancer, like an Olympic weight thrower, and he used the centrifugal force generated by his spin to launch her towards the hole in the wall with a small explosion of his own to propel her forwards.

100 milliseconds.

He hoped to god Sero would catch her too, and that he hadn't just sent her plunging to her death.

Since every action has an equal, opposite reaction, throwing her towards the hole had caused him to be thrown off his balance, just the slightest bit. He didn't waste time, though, red lightning coursing through him as he dashed towards his only escape route.

30 milliseconds.

He used another explosion to propel himself towards the hole next, right after her, because as much as he wanted to be a hero, he didn't want to die. Not yet. Not like this. Not here.

10 milliseconds.

He reached out towards the hole. Maybe he would make it. Maybe he'd been fast enough. Hatsume flew past the hole, her body free falling and disappearing from his line of sight.

1 millisecond.

The tips of his fingers made it out.

Then, the air dislodged by the explosion of the dynamite hit him, so intensely and so suddenly that he was sure he heard his ribs crack under the pressure. The blast shoved him away from the hole in the wall just as his fingertips reached it.

He'd been close. So close.

He couldn't die like this. What about his hero career and his future?

The future. Oh, fuck. He still had Deku's quirk.

He needed to give it back.

The loud roar of the explosion invaded his senses a split second after he was hit. His sight was overcome with white and orange as he was thrown all the way across the auditorium, the heat stronger than any Howitzer, stronger than anything he had ever produced before. And wasn't it ironic, that it would be an *explosion*, of all things, that would kill him?

Was his sweat making it worse? Or didn't it make enough of a difference? His whole body was drenched in nitroglycerin, so it couldn't be helping his side of things.

Why was time so fucking slow, anyway? Why had he been able to save everyone but himself? What kind of hero did that make him? How could he scold Deku now, after he did exactly what he always criticized the nerd for doing? Was this a fucking side effect of One For All?

Nah. The nerd had always been like that. He had already jumped at the Sludge Villain before he even had One For All. Maybe that recklessness was just a side effect of *Deku*.

Fuck, Deku. One For All. All Might's legacy. He still had it.

He had prioritized a rescue over the legacy of generations, the legacy of All Might. Over an unfathomable power that had been trusted upon him, that signified All Might's very essence.

And that he was supposed to *give back.*

You are one who remains true to his love to All Might and to his desire to surpass him as a hero. And that sentiment is what is going to help me obliterate All Might from history, once and for all.

He couldn't die like this. He wouldn't allow himself to. He couldn't die like th–

His body finally collided with something behind him and his skull snapped against a harsh surface. He immediately blacked out from the force of the blow.

He regained consciousness at some point, but he couldn't know how much time had passed. The only thing he knew was that his entire body hurt.

Both his arms had snapped from the pressure of One For All when he tried to propel himself out of the building after Hatsume. He tried to move them, and failed.

One of his ears was ringing. The other was completely silent. He couldn't hear anything around him – neither the fire cackling, nor the structure of the building groaning and wailing around him.

He didn't even have the time to process the pain of his arms. His world had been consumed by fire. He was vaguely aware that he was lying on his side, flames and debris scattered around him.

He was vaguely aware that he was lying on his side, flames and debris scattered around him.

He was vaguely aware that he was… lying on his side…? Flames and debris scattered around him…

He'd better get up and leave already before something worse happened. He needed to do something, but he couldn't really remember what it was for the life of him.

But it was important. So he needed to leave. He just needed… to…

There was… there was something important, but he couldn't… he couldn't remember…

He had to…

There was… flames and debris… scattered around him…?

Focus…

Focus…

Focus…

Katsuki managed to reopen his eyes in time to see the girders and the columns and the walls surrounding him give away. After them, the floor.

He mustered all the strength he had left to get up and make a run for the front exit of the auditorium, because he really, really wanted to survive this. As soon as he put weight on his broken arms to lift himself off the ground, he fell down again, his ribs protesting in the process.

The floor collapsed and disappeared from beneath his feet. He desperately tried to crawl away from the epicenter of ruin, but it was all for nothing. He grabbed a lose wire for support, but in a moment, it was gone, swollen by the whirlpool of concrete and broken chairs and debris. Katsuki got sucked into it, sliding down with it, unable to grasp anything else for support.

He couldn't die. Not like this.

The building collapsed with a loud roar that went unheard by his silenced ears, bringing him down with it. The lack of sound only made it all more terrifying, and the fact that he was

screaming in rage and determination and fear but couldn’t hear his own voice only made everything worse.

The building collapsed with Katsuki inside.

This is the way his world ends – not with a whimper but a loud-as-fuck bang.

Chapter End Notes

Anyone who thinks they should have made it upstairs faster has never been in a group project

Villain: I'm going to turn your love into hatred! Mwahaha!
Katsuki, who only knows how to process one emotion (which is rage): I'm about to end this man's whole career

But yeah. This is the chapter I've been waiting for MONTHS to write. It's also the one that inspired me to write this story. And the one I keep procrastinating to post because I was so afraid everyone would hate it. Anyway. Here it is. Hurray?

I've got my personal grudges against it, to be honest. The beginning feels too dragged. The ending feels too rushed. Idk. I really tried to capture how Katsuki's perception of time would change if he had access to OFA in a fight. Like I say often, I feel like he, just as much as Deku, is a character with a very fast mind, a fast thought process... The only difference is he doesn't mutter it aloud like Deku does. But it's all there, guys.

The first revising process I did of this was super rushed because I'm working from home during this quarantine crisis. Apparently, that's even MORE work than office work, and thus spare time is something I haven't been getting my hands on much lately. Then I started over-revising it because I was paranoid something had slipped. It probably did, by the way. I'll probably revise it again later for typos/inconsistencies when I finally stop thinking so much about it lol.

Just a disclaimer I feel the need to make, Katsuki couldn't have just grabbed Hatsume and jumped out with her. He was standing right next to the hole, she was standing at the entrance of the auditorium. The hole was blown at the front. He had to go all the way back to grab her, and then back to the front again. That's a lot of time to waste when there's a bunch of dynamite about to go off on your face. If they went together, there was a chance neither would make it out in time, and then they'd both die. Poor Katsuki just chose the option with the higher stakes to save most lives, because he's a great thinker and a true hero :-(

(We can't know for sure they wouldn't have both made it out if they went together. Katsuki could have been wrong about the risk... But don't tell him I said that.)

If you want to be mad at Hatsume for going back even though she didn't know about the bomb, consider this: Katsuki got hurt because of her and her invention was used for evil purposes. Angsty potential, amirite?

Anyway. A reminder because it's always good to reinforce this: THIS IS NOT A DEATHFIC. I'm a COWARD. So don't worry. There WILL be some comfort to all this hurt soon. And no one will die. And there will be a happy ending. Eventually.

On a final note, I hope this chapter helps distract you guys amidst this world crisis we're living. Please stay safe and stay home if you can! If you can't stay home, thank you for everything you're doing for those who are on lockdown and take care! Wash your hands, disinfect your bathrooms... And if any of you feel suffocated by the quarantine, feel free to vent to me on twitter or on tumblr. We all need to support each other during this sad moment of crisis, and I'm always here to lend an ear (even if I do take a while to respond sometimes because of work, so if I don't reply right away, I'm not ignoring you!). Sending my best wishes and nice energies to all of you!

See you next time! Kudos and comments are appreciated ^_^

Chapter 25: The Hero He Thought He Would Never Get To Be

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku was still paralyzed when the explosion happened.

He was lying on his back, on a stretcher, Todoroki's cold hand a firm presence on his shoulder. He could hear Uraraka's and Iida's voice somewhere above his head, but they weren't standing in his direct line of sight, so he couldn't see them. He was vaguely aware that Kaminari was somewhere beside him as well, but he couldn't see him either.

All he could see was the building, standing tall above them, and the blurry forms of some paramedics who rushed by in front of him, ready to tend to those who were still too dazed by what had happened. A couple ambulances and a few police cars had already arrived on the site, as well as some pro heroes who had been nearest to the museum. Izuku recognized some of their voices, even if he couldn't see them directly – Mount Lady and Kamui Woods, Mirko… It seemed Matsuo-kun had not taken his task of calling for help for granted.

Apparently even Aizawa sensei was there, since the man's tired face suddenly entered Izuku's vision, staring down at him with a disapproving look.

Had he been anyone else, Izuku would have described him as disheveled – as if he had rushed to get there in time. His face, on the other hand, was completely stoic as he offered Izuku an analytical look.

"Trouble kid", Aizawa sensei scoffed simply, his eyes impassive.

Izuku wanted to reply to him, but all he managed to do was flex his throat as he swallowed dry, still paralyzed. Upon his silence and limpness, the teacher raised his head to look up at something – probably at Todoroki, who was standing vigil behind Izuku's stretcher.

"What's the situation?"

"His head needs to be looked at", Todoroki provided promptly. "They're still gathering everyone who needs medical attention, but so far Midoriya is the only one who will actually need the hospital. Other than the head injury, he was paralyzed by one of the villain's quirk, as was Kaminari. The effect is still wearing off".

Aizawa sensei glanced down at Izuku again, taking in his state.

"And where might the other trouble kid be?", he asked in his usual monotone.

"Up there", Todoroki provided calmly, nodding at the museum building. "He didn't want to leave the villains there on their own in case they tried to escape, so he stayed with them. The police said they're about to go in for the arr–"

A loud noise interrupted them, making Aizawa, Todoroki, and everybody nearby flinch in surprise.

It sounded like… one of Kacchan's explosions?

"Oh my god!", Uraraka's voice exclaimed in shock and horror from behind them. "Is that –?"

Izuku's eyes darted around, desperate to see what could have caused such a reaction. He couldn't turn his head, but from the corner of his eyes, he spotted something – someone – far, far away, flying across the sky, but he couldn't understand who it was or what was happening –

"Is that –?", Iida repeated, worry evident in his usually collected tone.

"Huh?", other people were starting to whisper and gasp around them.

Two more people flew out of the building after the first one, and Izuku could see, even from the distance, the long string of tape that shot up across the air and tangled itself on the window of the building directly nearby. Was that… Sero?

Sero managed to grab the two other people that flew out with him and secured them in his arms after he shot out the tape, but before the three of them could even collide painfully with the wall of the building in front of them, something else happened.

There was another person – someone else flying out after them. Sero, out of reflex, used his free elbow to shoot out another tape towards the flaying person, and Mount Lady, who had been standing on the opposite side of this whole mess, seemed to be already growing in size in order to grab them, just a few seconds behind. And why were there even people *flying* out of the building as if they had been launched in the first place –

"Get down –!", Todoroki's brain caught up with what was happening a split second too late. Just as people began to make sense of his warning, a deafening sound invaded Izuku's senses.

He couldn't squint, or flinch, or even attempt to protect his face, as any other person would in that situation. Because of his paralysis, all he could do was lie there, as still as a statue, at the same time as white and orange and red overcame his vision and a loud explosion assaulted his ears. He couldn't even close his eyes properly as pebbles and dust immediately rained down on his face, scratching and stinging against his skin.

Todoroki threw himself above Izuku on the stretcher, trying to shield his head from most of the rubble. The aftermath of the explosion was still strong enough to send Izuku, Todoroki, and the stretcher flying back, and they all collided with the floor and rolled across it because of the wind force.

The next moment, a tall wall of ice surged between the people and the building, large enough to cocoon everyone that was directly nearby. Todoroki's ice stopped most of the rubble cascading from the blown-up building from hitting the people down there, even if everyone had, like Izuku, been pushed back by the sudden burst of air.

A split moment of silence came, during which everyone just breathed and tried to gather themselves – to make sense of what was happening. Some people were crying, other people were gasping, but all Izuku could see was the white-blue ice wall looming far above him.

His view range was limited from where he was spread on the floor, but he knew Todoroki wasn't the only one trying to protect the people around them. From behind the tall wall of ice, he could see a part of Mount Lady's gigantic head – she had fully grown and thrown herself between the building and the people below her. Whether she or Sero had managed to grab the fourth person who had flown out, Izuku couldn't tell, which sent his heart racing inside his chest. *Are they ok?*

"Are you ok?", Todoroki appeared above him, his face and hair dusty.

His multicolored eyes were wide as they scanned Izuku for injuries and waited for an answer – until it clicked, a couple seconds later, that there was no way Izuku could possibly reply just yet. Todoroki turned to prob and poke at him instead, trying to feel for anything broken or out of place, while Izuku just laid there, helpless to move or to do anything at all.

Incapable of helping anyone, let alone himself.

Who knew how many injured people they were dealing with now? Who knew how much the number of people who would need the hospital had grown in just the past few seconds? Had Sero and the others made it out ok? Kacchan was with them, right? Had he caused the explosion? Why did he do that? Had the villains tried something? Was he ok? Were *they* ok?

"Midoriya", Todoroki told him, a firm hand finding his shoulder. "Stop overthinking. Breathe instead", he instructed, firm.

Izuku realized his breathing was irregular. He swallowed again, which was the most he could do at the time, before trying to calm his racing heart. Even if he regained his movements, he wouldn't be able to help anyone if he was freaking out. He needed to stay calm and rational, like All Might always was in moments of crisis. But that was a difficult task when your movements were completely frozen to the point you couldn't even flinch right after a building exploded.

Todoroki was still checking him for injuries when the building started to groan.

There was a pause that couldn't have lasted more than a second, but felt like an eternity. Izuku's widening eyes darted around in panic as he tried to see what was happening, at the same time Todoroki's head snapped to the side in order to look at the ruined building standing above them, his hands still pressed against Izuku.

Less than a minute had passed between the explosion and the groaning, and most people had been too busy recovering from the shock and trying to get back to their feet to bother running away. Some people *couldn't* run away. No one had thought –

"Clear out of here!", Aizawa sensei shouted with authority from somewhere to their left. Izuku couldn't see him, but the urgency in his voice was evident. "Everyone, clear out –"

The place became a pandemonium of screaming and running – but Izuku couldn't participate. All he could do was lie there helplessly as he was dragged and pulled and picked up into someone's arms – he didn't even know if it was Todoroki anymore. His vision was swimming as he was carried away, body rocking limply and in unison with each of his carrier's jogs.

He couldn't see past the smoke and the debris and the wall of ice they were leaving behind. Everything was happening too fast; he was completely lost.

His eyes kept searching the panicked crowd for any signs of Kacchan, because the final explosion could only mean he had gotten out, right? Izuku had been worried sick when the four bodies flew out, because none of them could have been Kacchan. He wouldn't allow Sero to carry him out when he could propel himself with his explosions; he also wouldn't just free fall off a building waiting to be caught, because of that same reason.

Which meant the last explosion *had* to be Kacchan getting out. Maybe he had produced a blast that turned out too strong and accidentally set the bomb Jirou had disarmed off. Maybe one of the villains tried something funny and he was forced to counter-attack. There *had* to be an explanation to all that – a rational one, one that wouldn't get him in trouble with the police or with UA when they got out of this.

But as Izuku looked and looked and looked as best as he could, given his current circumstances, he found no sign of that spiky blond hair; no trace of those crimson narrow eyes or of that familiar scowl.

Izuku didn't allow himself to panic, however. Because he *knew* Kacchan wouldn't let himself be defeated by a villain so low, by someone so beneath him. A villain who kidnapped people and attempted to brainwash them. A villain who used people's love for All Might in such a despicable way.

Kacchan was fine. He had to be. Just because Izuku couldn't see him, it didn't mean he wasn't in one piece. They *really* needed to cut out this whole over-worry-about-each-other's-safety thing they had going on. It was verging on unhealthy.

(But Izuku had to admit that finding at least a glimpse of Kacchan amidst all those running, desperate people would do *wonders* for his current state of mind.)

His frantic eyes managed to spot Sero and Mina as he was rushed by. They were being dragged and urged into running away from the building by a dust-covered Aizawa sensei. Izuku didn't really understand why there were tear tracks on Mina's face, or why Sero seemed so… feral? He was trying to fight his way past Aizawa sensei, Izuku realized, frantically shouting something Izuku couldn't hear and pointing urgently at somewhere Izuku couldn't see.

A piercing scream from a voice that sounded weirdly familiar resonated from somewhere to his left, but Izuku couldn't see who it was coming from. He was desperate to look and to help the person, but the most he managed at that point was a twist of his pinky finger.

Then, with a loud, lamenting wail, the building collapsed behind them.

It happened fast, but also slow. His perception of time was messed up, he had to admit that. All he knew was that, in one moment, he was being rushed away and staring at Sero, and in the other, after a loud noise, he was on the floor, body askew and eyes stinging. He didn't even remember falling.

His whole body ached, and yet, he couldn't move.

Dust, smoke, people screaming and crying. That was what Izuku's world consisted of for what felt like hours, but couldn't have been more than seconds. The person carrying him tried to shield him from the destruction, because even Todoroki's wall of ice wasn't thick enough to hold back the sea of rubble and concrete that erupted from the wreck. It collapsed, huge blocks of ice about to crash down on the already panicking people.

Intense heat erupted from somewhere beside him, or maybe above him? He couldn't tell. All he knew was suddenly there was rain, cold water splashing on his face. It was confusing. So confusing. If the water was cold, why did the air feel so hot?

Todoroki's using his left side to melt the blocks of ice before they hurt anyone, Izuku's racing brain supplied.

All right. That made sense. But not only did that mean Todoroki was using his left side again, it also meant he was probably under a huge strain, if he had to melt a whole ice *wall* in the matter of seconds. Izuku tried to look, to at least find him with his darting eyes, but he couldn't.

He couldn't see or hear anything. His ears were ringing violently and his sight was obscured by white dust and mud. His heart was beating so hard and fast inside his chest he was sure it was about to jump out of his body, he was sure, he was sure.

By the time everything started to settle again and the ringing in his ears toned down, he managed to pick up the broken sounds of the people around him. So much distress, and pain, and fear. There were people crying and breathing hard and even whimpering nearby. Izuku felt so desperate to help them, and so frustrated that he couldn't. This was a horrific situation, and yet he couldn't do anything to stop it. He couldn't do anything to aid those people's suffering, to diminish it. He couldn't even move on his own. It was driving him insane.

I'm tired of being like this. Weak. Of needing help all the time, of being treated like I'm made of porcelain. I just want to feel good again. I – I just want to…

Todoroki's face entered his blurred field of vision again, face white. His scar was gone beneath the thick beige dust covering his head, and the red half of his hair wasn't even distinguishable from the white half anymore. Sweat was pooling on the left side of his forehead, starting to run down his face and reveal the red of his scar beneath thin streaks that were clear of dust.

He was coughing and wheezing as he kneeled beside Izuku on the floor, looking exhausted but thankfully unharmed. Izuku still tried to scan him for injuries as best as he could without moving his head.

Uraraka and Tsuyu appeared from the mist of dust behind him, equally white. They were shaking and supporting each other's weights, but Izuku couldn't see any blood or apparent injuries, which was good. Or – or at least as good as it could be in that situation.

"Midoriya", Todoroki was saying, but his voice sounded far away and echo-y, as if Izuku's hearing wasn't at its full capacity just yet.

Maybe it wasn't. His ears were still ringing, and he *did* still have a concussion, which didn't make his head hurt so bad anymore but was still making him kind of dizzy…

A hand tapped his cheek and he realized his eyes had been slipping shut. Which was… weird. He couldn't fall asleep. There were people who needed help, and he hadn't found Kacchan just yet. He reopened his eyes wide, staring up at Todoroki with attention. Forcing himself to focus.

"Midoriya, can you hear me?", Todoroki gave him a worried look.

He tried to nod, but couldn't just yet. He tried to say something, but his throat refused to move. All he could do was stare at Todoroki and hope that his friend would understand he was lucid, fingers twitching weakly beside his rigid body.

"You still can't move, right?", Todoroki asked, squeezing his shoulder.

Izuku just stared at him.

"Ok", Todoroki nodded, but for some reason it looked like he was nodding to himself. "Stay here. Even if you get your movements back, don't leave this spot. I'll be back for you. *Stay here*", he told Izuku.

Then, he was gone.

Izuku stayed where he was, since he didn't have a say in that matter. He was lying on the dusty floor, body tilted slightly to the side, blinking his tears of frustration and worry away as he stared at all those people helplessly.

From what it seemed, Mount Lady had managed to use her grown body to shield everyone from most of the debris, but there was nothing her gigantic form could have done about the wave of dust that erupted from the demolition. She was nowhere to be seen, now, which sent another twinge of worry and guilt to Izuku's chest. *Did she get hurt? Is she ok? A whole building came down right behind her, maybe she was hit by debris? Maybe she is injured?*

He wanted to do something. He *needed* to do something. People were suffering and he was just lying there, distant, separated. This was torture. This was… This was…

(*Probably what Kacchan expects you to do all the time*, his brain supplied bitterly.)

He shuddered.

Kacchan. Where was Kacchan? Why hadn't he been with Mina and Sero and Aizawa sensei? Were the three of them ok? Had they managed to run away in time?

But Jirou hadn't been with them, either. Neither had the fourth person who flew off the building. Maybe Kacchan was with them. Maybe he was helping people somewhere else. He was fine, right? Of course he was fine. Izuku wasn't going to freak out over Kacchan like Kacchan had freaked out over him. He had to be the better person in this situation, and there was no reason to panic. Kacchan was *sugoi*, he would be all right.

There is no reason to panic. There is no reason to panic.

He trusted Kacchan's competence, he trusted Kacchan's ability. He wasn't going to crowd him. He was fine. He was fine. He wasn't going to freak out over this. *There is no reason to panic.*

Izuku's heart continued to beat very fast.

The people that were standing in Izuku's direct line of sight didn't seem to be hurt – just a little shaken up, which he was thankful for. They didn't look familiar and were probably just civilians who had been attending to the museum, which in its own turn was horrible.

They didn't have the training Izuku or his friends had. They shouldn't be in this situation.

God. If the explosion and the building had really been Kacchan's doing… Izuku *really, really* hoped he wouldn't get in trouble for it. So many people might have gotten hurt, and so many of them were clearly distraught…

There was no UA would let him out of this so easily this time, if it really was his fault. From what Izuku had heard, most people in the sewer incident had been villains. The few students who accompanied Kacchan, like Todoroki and Jirou, had been punished for their actions, just as much as Kacchan. And, above all, they were heroes in training.

But now? Now, there were civilians involved. Hundreds of them. And Izuku didn't even know if there was someone gravely hurt, or… or even…

He shuddered again.

And then someone screaming in the distance brought him back to reality, his eyes widening. It was the same familiar scream from before – the same person he couldn't really pinpoint, but that he was sure he knew...

In the blink of an eye, Uraraka was kneeling beside him, taking Todoroki's place.

Izuku found he didn't really like how white her hair looked because of all that dust… It didn't really go with her brown eyes, and the fact that her eyebrows had also disappeared beneath beige was a bit unsettling too. The permanent flush of his face was useable beneath the dust, making her look pale, like a ghost.

It took him longer than he should have to realize she was talking to him while he stared at her hair. He looked at her lips, trying to comprehend the words past the constant ringing of his ears.

“ – to keep you company, ok? Iida-kun said the pros could use my quirk to help someone, so please, stay here until one of us comes back, ok? Deku-kun?”

Izuku blinked up at her. He found that, other than being able to move all his fingers now, he could also wiggle his toe and his ankles. But he still couldn’t speak yet. So, upon his silence, she tightened her lips and squeezed his arm before standing up and running off, like Todoroki had.

“I’ll stay with you, Midoriya-chan”, Tsuyu said, taking his side immediately. She held a hand to his arm as if she wanted to make sure he would stay where he was, even though he couldn’t really move yet.

And why were people doing that, anyway? Taking turns watching him? He was sure Tsuyu could be somewhere else, helping other people with Uraraka. Not that he minded her company, of course he didn’t, and it was very considerate of her to stay there with him, but he didn’t need to be watched. He would be ok once he got his movements back and maybe took a painkiller for his head.

His major concern on that moment was the other people, the ones who weren’t training to be heroes and therefore had no idea what to do in a situation like this. And the person who was screaming – they also needed help, right? A *lot* of people needed more help than he did, and the pros could probably use all available hands on deck right now. If Izuku wasn’t able to offer his own help, he wished that at least people wouldn’t be kept from helping because of him. People like Tsuyu.

“ – the stretcher, come on, over here!”, a voice he didn’t recognize instructed, and then a lot of people were surrounding him out of a sudden.

Izuku tried to look, but he couldn’t move his head or his neck just yet. He wondered if Kaminari was in the same situation, but there was no sign of the boy – which was yet another topic for his long list of concerns. Had someone carried him away, like Todoroki had done for him?

“Gather the injured over there until more ambulances arrive! They’re going to start the search for the boy, so we need the room! Get them out of there!”, another voice shouted.

The boy? What boy? Izuku’s thoughts were interrupted as someone picked him up from the floor and placed him heavily onto another stretcher, Tsuyu following him closely.

“You’ll be all right, Midoriya-chan”, she reassured him, grabbing his arm again, which was… weird. Coming from her.

Not that she wasn’t a reassuring person, but there was something about the way she said it, almost as if she was trying to calm a wounded animal… Which Izuku definitely wasn’t, he would be fine. His head wasn’t even hurt that bad. Sure, he kept getting side-tracked in his thoughts, but –

“*No!*”, the voice that kept screaming in the distance got closer. Apparently, the person had been dragged into the makeshift medical area as well, and dropped on a stretcher next to

Izuku.

His movements were still very limited and stiff, but he managed to turn his head the slightest bit to the side in order to look at the screaming person. Instead, he caught a glimpse of Kaminari, lying on the stretcher directly beside him and looking just as paralyzed as he felt.

Izuku felt a tiny bit of relief course through him as he saw his friend seemed ok. He was covered in as much dust as Todoroki had been, which made him wonder if he *also* looked like that. Was the green from his hair gone beneath all that beige dust? Were the freckles on his cheeks even seeable anymore?

"Stop it! Don't touch it!", the screaming person shrieked, bringing Izuku's attention back to reality. He would have flinched if he could, the sheer pain in the voice sending an ice stab of concern across his heart.

He *really* needed to stop getting sidetracked. He knew it was because of his concussion, which was probably made worse by the explosion and the collapse, but this was a *crisis*. He needed to focus.

Ok, right. Familiar person screaming. He needed to see who it was –

Tsuyu stepped in front of him. Purposefully blocking his view.

Izuku tried to frown, and found that he could.

"Miss, please, you need to stay still", someone was telling the screaming person. "Please, you'll disrupt your shoulder further –"

"*Don't* – Don't touch it!", the person moaned in agony, voice hoarse from all the screaming, and Izuku frowned in recognition.

That was… Hatsume?

He couldn't remember ever hearing her scream before. The sound was terrifying.

And what could have possibly happened to her in order to have her screaming so much, in so much pain?

He tried to crane his neck again to take a look at her, but Tsuyu blocked his view once more. She had a weird look on her face.

"We need sedation here!", someone – Izuku presumed it was a paramedic – yelled from behind the frog girl.

Even with Tsuyu standing in front of him, Izuku could see Kaminari's fingers twitching on his own stretcher. Good, he wasn't the only one getting back to normal. But he couldn't see Kaminari's face – not with her body blocking the view.

He looked up at her again. He tried to question her, to ask why she was doing that – why couldn't he look at Hatsume? He might not be that close to her, but he cared about her. She

sounded like she was in pain. He was worried. He wanted to ensure she was going to be ok.

But as he tried to move his tongue and form the words, he found that he couldn't. Not yet, at least. His felt like there was cotton filling his mouth.

"How is he doing?", Iida materialized behind Tsuyu, frowning at Izuku. His glasses were gone, and his face was just as dusty as everyone else's. There was an ugly scratch on his forehead, but it didn't seem to be bleeding much. Izuku still frowned in worry.

"He's getting his movements back", Tsuyu provided. "But he still can't move properly".

"Good", Iida nodded.

Wait. *Good?* How could that possibly be good for anyone?

"We're almost done collecting everyone", he continued. "Some people will need the hospital, but thankfully no one was gravely injured. Well, apart from…"

A somber silence. Tsuyu offered Iida a reproaching look, which was very uncharacteristic of her. Iida promptly looked away, ashamed.

"Can you stay with him a bit longer?", Iida continued, avoiding Izuku's eyes.

"Of course", Tsuyu said compliantly.

"Thank you, Tsuyu-chan-kun", Iida made to leave, but then his eyes found Hatsume lying just a stretcher away.

He looked back at Tsuyu.

"How is Hatsume-san?"

"I don't know. They just brought her in, but she seemed very distraught".

Iida nodded solemnly.

A beat.

"Does he –"

"No", Tsuyu cut him off before he could finish. "Also, he can hear you, Iida-chan".

Iida's lips formed a thin line, but he nodded.

He took a step towards Izuku, looking like he wanted to talk to him, or perhaps tell him something… But then just as fast he retreated, guilt weighting heavy on his face.

Izuku frowned again. What was going on?

"I'll be right back", Iida announced briefly.

Then he was gone.

And ok, something was definitely wrong. And Izuku had no idea what it was.

Well, a building had just collapsed. Izuku could only imagine, with the heaviest of hearts, how many injured people there must be. Were his friends worried that he would try to help those people, even if he was slightly injured?

Well… of course he would try to help. It was in his nature; he couldn't simply lie on a stretcher doing nothing if he had the power to aid those who needed it. So, he could see where his friends' worries were coming from. But there was still something wrong about it – something off about Iida's and Tsuyu's interaction, or the way she didn't want him to look at Hatsume, or the way she had warned Iida about him being able to hear them.

There was something cold twisting at the bottom of Izuku's stomach. What was going on?

And… Where was Kacchan?

A few more people were brought into the improvised medical area the paramedics had created. Like Iida had said, most of the injured didn't seem to be extremely hurt, which Izuku was really relieved for, but his heart was squeezed with concern when he saw Jirou being dragged in, the bright red of her blood contrasting starkly with the whiteness of the dust covering her.

Beside them, Hatsume continued to groan and moan in pain, but she didn't sound too coherent anymore. Had they sedated her already? Izuku was desperate to aid her, or at least to console her in a way.

"I-It's ok, I'm f-f-fine", Jirou told the paramedic that was helping her sit down.

"Miss, please, let us take care of you", the paramedic told her in a soft voice. "You're bleeding, and your ears need to be cared for".

"I'm n-not the one you s-should be –" she started, but cut herself off before she could finish, deflating.

Izuku noticed she was pointedly avoiding to look at his general direction. Instead, she met the paramedic's eyes.

"T-There are people who need y-your attention more than I d-do", she stuttered, shaking like a leaf. Noticing this, the paramedic enveloped her in a shock blanket.

"That does not change the fact that you still need my attention", the woman told her, placing a comforting hand on her shoulder. "Now please sit still while I gather what I need, ok?"

The paramedic walked away to grab her equipment. Jirou sat there compliantly, staring at the floor and looking like she was struggling to hold back tears.

She looked disoriented and shocked, the blanket enveloping her shoulders only contributing to that image. Even from where he was lying on the stretcher, Izuku could notice the way she

was shaking, her hands grasping the edges of the blanket as she hugged herself.

He frowned and rolled his tongue inside his mouth, trying to remember the months of speech therapy he was forced to do and attempting to form words. He was still pretty stiff overall, but his legs and arms were back to life. He turned his head to look at Jirou.

“J-J… J-Ji…”, he croaked out.

Tsuyu held a hand to his shoulder.

“Midoriya-chan”, she said, her voice a mixture of a pleading and a warning.

But Izuku couldn’t really think about that on that moment. There was something wrong, something weird about the way Jirou was avoiding his eyes, or the way everyone was making sure he wasn’t left alone, or the way his stomach was twisting inside him.

Or the way Kacchan was nowhere to be seen yet.

“J-Jir… Jirou… k-k-k-un”, he forced out.

And then, to his horror, Jirou burst into tears at the call of her name.

She covered her mouth to muffle the sound, but the damage was done. And if Izuku hadn’t been freaking out before, he was definitely freaking out now.

Something was wrong.

“There, there, darling girl”, the paramedic came back with what she needed to tend to Jirou’s ears. “You took some nasty damage, there. The new ambulances will arrive any minute now, so you don’t have to worry. Does it hurt too much? Do you want me to give you something for the pain?”

She shook her head vehemently, still hiding her pale face away from Izuku and attempting to hide her sobs behind her hand. And Izuku knew this was definitely not the best time, but there was something dreadful pooling inside him. Something… Something…

“J-J-Jirou-k-kun”, he attempted again, the words coming out more coherent now that he had gotten used to moving his tongue again. His mobility was mostly back, now, even if his members were still very stiff and overall rigid.

With a great effort, he turned on the stretcher, his knuckles becoming white as he gripped the edge of the mattress in order to support his body into a half-sitting position.

“Midoriya-chan, you shouldn’t be moving so much”, Tsuyu reprimanded from behind him. Her hands were attempting to urge him back into a lying position, albeit gently. He hated himself for it, but he ignored her.

His eyes were fixed on Jirou’s tear-tracked face.

“W-W-Where”, he croaked out.

Tsuyu's hands grew more insistent.

"Please, lie back down –"

Izuku closed his eyes, swallowing dry and focusing on what he needed to do. He was getting his movements back. He could already move his arms and legs and fingers. He could manage something as simple as asking a question.

He put all those months of speech therapy into practice.

"Where's K-K-Kacchan?", Izuku mustered out.

Silence fell upon them. Suddenly, even Hatsume's pain-filled lament quieted down.

Because Jirou wasn't responding.

No "he's fine, just out there saving people and being an idiot", no "he's kicking the villain's ass", not even a "he's getting his injuries tended somewhere else", which would have been frightening but also a bit more reassuring.

There was *no* answer. Which, added to the unnecessary surveillance Izuku was currently undergoing and the overly careful way all his friends were acting around him, could only mean one thing.

It could only mean one dreadful, unfathomable, *ineffable* thing.

It could only mean something had happened to Kacchan, and they didn't want Izuku to go after him.

"I-Is he… still t-there?", Izuku choked out, eyes widening in horror. "Is h-he in the b-building?"

Jirou turned her face away from him with a muffled sob. His eyes then searched Tsuyu's face for answers instead, desperate for any sort of explanation.

The sorrowful look in her expressive eyes told him everything he needed to know, no matter how hard she tried to hide it.

Kacchan was the boy the paramedics were talking about. Kacchan was the exception Iida had mentioned.

He was still in the building.

And, as it always happened to Izuku when it came to Kacchan –

– His body moved before he could really think about it.

Everything was a blur.

He could hear Tsuyu's and Jirou's desperate voices calling after him. He could hear the paramedic's surprised gasp, and Hatsume's pained grunts coming back to life when the world came back into tune around him. Tsuyu tried to grab a hold of him with her tongue when he rolled off the mattress and collapsed with the floor, but missed by millimeters.

Suddenly, he could see everything. The colors were sharper, the sounds were louder, even the nauseating smell of the dust was more intense and suffocating. As he ran, his legs didn't feel so stiff anymore – or, if they did, Izuku didn't have the time to notice. Adrenaline was filling his veins – things as trivial as muscle pains or concussions were just afterthoughts to him at this point.

Because Kacchan was in danger.

People tried to stop him, of course. Iida was the first, the first familiar face he rushed by. But Izuku pushed him out of the way without a second thought – without as much as an ounce of guilt. Iida was strong, he would be fine.

Next was Todoroki. He was the first who actually managed to grab Izuku, but, due to some miracle, Izuku managed to twist himself away from his hold before Todoroki could freeze him or immobilize him. Little a cat, Izuku wiggled himself free from his friend's arms, running away before he had the chance to grab him again. Todoroki knew better than to try and freeze his feet, because Izuku was running so fast his knee would probably pop off its socket if Todoroki froze him into such an abrupt stop.

Then, Uraraka and Yaoyorozu. They both jumped at him at the same time, but Izuku dodged and rolled to the side. Before he could get back up, Yaoyorozu grabbed his leg amidst a plea of "Midoriya-kun, please, wait –", but he paid her no mind. Uraraka managed to throw herself atop him, but Izuku rolled away before she had the chance to pin him down, stumbling his way back to his feet and resuming his run. He shouted a barely hearable "I'm sorry" over his shoulder as he went. He knew he hadn't hurt them, but he also knew he was letting them down.

Surprisingly, it didn't matter. There was nothing that could stop him on a moment like this.

He ran past the police force, he ran past a group of firemen that tried – and failed – to stop him, he ran past the remains of the destroyed wall of ice, he ran past Kirishima desperately

attempting to free himself from the grasp of Kamui Woods, who was keeping him from doing exactly what Izuku was about to do.

Izuku launched himself towards the wall of debris, bloodied fingers gripping and clinging to the concrete, legs and arms working together to climb up. He paid no mind to the hands that tried to grab him, to the urgent calls of his name, to the pieces of support items that brushed against his feet and legs in their desperate attempt to snatch him back.

He rolled over a huge girder and disappeared from everyone else's view.

He was lucky, honestly. Mount Lady had probably been injured after the building collapsed, otherwise she could have just grabbed him as if he was an insect. Aizawa sensei was probably busy helping people far away, otherwise he could have just immobilized Izuku with his binding cloth. There were a lot of factors that could – and should – have stopped him from doing this, his recently overcome paralysis being the primary of them, but none had: which could mean that *maybe* the universe was being merciful for once and finally allowing him to *save Kacchan.*

Or maybe his sheer will to make sure Kacchan was safe was strong enough to override any possible circumstance that could get in his way.

What he was met with was a sea of debris and a still high cloud of dust and smoke ahead of him. The building had sunken down below ground-level, meaning there was a concrete-filled crater beneath his shaking body. He would need to climb down if he ever expected to find Kacchan, but at least he had been on the eleventh floor of the building, right? That was the last floor, which meant there shouldn't be too much concrete above him. Maybe there was even a chance… A chance that…

Izuku shook his head with determination before his thoughts could thread a somber path. Biting his lower lip, he concentrated on his descent, ignoring the calls of his name that were still coming from behind the destruction.

"Midoriya! Come back!"

"Deku-kun! You can't go there, it's unstable!"

"Midoriya-kun!"

"Let me through! Let me go after him!"

"*Midoriya-kun*!"

His legs were trembling violently because of the villain's quirk – and probably from the strain Izuku had put on them immediately after regaining his movements. He was careful to test his weight on the pieces of concrete he was taking support on before he climbed down, but the debris really *were* unstable.

His face was the picture of concentration as he carefully made his way down, sweat starting to blossom on his injured forehead. He had managed to climb half of the way before a broken

chair that was supporting his left foot gave way.

His bleeding fingers latched to a block of concrete above him in time to prevent his fall, but as soon as that became the only thing supporting his weight, it started to slide. Gravity's pull on him was strong, and there was little Izuku could do before the concrete collapsed and he was sent rolling the rest of the way down with a surprised yelp and muffled grunts.

His back collided with a huge broken girder when his descent came to a stop. His vision swam for a moment as he tried to regain his senses, everything around him spinning and blurring together before he finally managed to blink his eyes back into focus.

The concrete he had been holding on to crashed heavily just a meter beside his head a second later, pebbles and rocks and all sort of smaller debris rolling down after it. The whole ground trembled and groaned beneath him at the disruption, threatening to collapse further inwards.

Ok. Ok. Unstable wreckage. Loose rubble everywhere. He could be crushed by debris at any moment. He would need to be more careful.

"Ouch", Izuku groaned as he sat back up, rubbing his sore head and fighting off a dizzy spell. The calls of his name were starting to die down in the distance.

Rationally, Izuku knew he would get in a lot of trouble for this. Rescue operations were the work of pros. Actually, *everything* they had done during the hijack was the work of pros. The thing was: there hadn't been any pros around when they found out about the villains, so they had been forced to take the matters into their own hands.

Now, there were pros outside. They were probably doing whatever they could to get Kacchan out without disrupting the building and causing a worse collapse, and Izuku had probably just thrown himself in their way. What he had done had been impulsive and reckless, just as Kacchan criticized him so much.

But so had been fighting the Sludge Villain. So had been trying to chase Kacchan when the League got him, so had been following Kirishima's plan to rescue Kacchan. Apparently, all traces of Izuku's rationality and (poor) sense of self-preservation always flew out the window whenever it came to Kacchan.

He couldn't just sit around and wait when it came to Kacchan's well-being. And he couldn't just sit around and wait when Kacchan's life was in danger and no one seemed to be doing anything to help.

No pro had stepped in when Kacchan was attacked by the Sludge Villain. No pro had tried to snatch Kacchan from the hands of the League before they could take him. No pro had rushed to his aid while All Might fought All For One.

And none of that had ever stopped Izuku.

That wouldn't change just because he was injured – he had tried to save Kacchan in a worse shape, with two broken arms. That wouldn't change because he was quirkless – he had tried

to save Kacchan when he didn't even fathom the possibility of getting a quirk in the first place.

That wouldn't change because they spent months either ignoring each other or having heated arguments. That had been Izuku's whole life before UA in a nutshell.

And screw everything he had been thinking before about being the better person. He would *always* worry about Kacchan, no matter what beef they had between them, no matter how much Kacchan doubted his ability. And he had been stupid to ever try to convince himself otherwise.

He had been stupid. So, so stupid.

(And maybe he could understand Kacchan's behavior at the park a bit better, now, even if he still disagreed with it.)

Around him, concrete and broken girders painted the scenario of the destroyed building. He had reached the "bottom" of the debris – the part where enough rubble was piled up for him to stand on, rather than climb. He could even walk, if he was careful enough and hopped his way around over broken girders and boulders of cement. He was sinisterly aware that there were still eleven floors worth of concrete beneath him, and that the whole structure was fragile and could come down any minute now.

And Kacchan was there somewhere.

Izuku felt angry at himself, as he carefully searched the debris for any signs of his childhood friend. He had just *assumed* Kacchan was ok, that he had flown his way out of the explosion without a scratch. And all that time he had wasted on thinking Kacchan was in one-piece could have been spent on finding Kacchan and getting him help.

He knew Kacchan would hate him for thinking he was helpless. Which was why Izuku *didn't* think that – why he had so easily assumed Kacchan had gotten out before the building came down. And because of that, because of his mistake, if anything happened to Kacchan – if… if the *worst* happened to Kacchan, that would be on Izuku.

He had been so stupid. He should have known something was wrong the very *second* Kacchan didn't show up to scream at his face for being an idiot.

"Kacchan", Izuku called, his voice raspy from all the dust he was breathing in. "K-Kacchan!", he managed to call louder.

He was stumbling his way above the debris with shaking legs, careful not to disrupt anything that could bring the unstable structure down. A few small fires were burning across some of the fallen structure, but the smoke emerging from them was nothing compared to the dust.

Izuku's nose and throat felt clogged, as if he was breathing in dry mud rather than air. When he started to feel even more dizzy from the lack of oxygen, he pulled the collar of his bloodied shirt to the bridge of his nose, holding it in place with one hand. He hoped this would serve as a makeshift filter and at least ease his breathing somehow.

(He hated the fact that the shirt Kacchan had given him was probably ruined beyond repair at this point.)

While his brain worked as fast as it possibly could to calculate which pieces of concrete were safe to move and which ones weren't, his free hand carefully dug and pushed away the small blocks that weren't likely to result in another collapse. He tried to catch as much as a glimpse of Kacchan while did this, but so far, his efforts had been fruitless.

His heart was still beating fast inside his chest. Too fast. With each passing second, he tried to pep-talk himself into controlling his heavy breathing and trying to slow his heartrate down, but this was getting harder with each stone he moved only to find no signs of Kacchan.

Izuku was reaching a point where he could barely breathe as he tried his best to focus on his task at hands – find Kacchan – and ignore the fear nagging at the back of his neck: that there was nothing left of Kacchan to find.

Ok. None of that. Get it together, Izuku. You need to ease your mind and concentrate on what you're doing.

Oh, how Kacchan would hate him, knowing that Izuku was doubting him.

Kacchan was there somewhere, and Izuku would find him. *Alive*. There was no other option. There was *no* other outcome. There was no sense in even doubting that.

He couldn't doubt that.

He didn't know how the building had become such a destroyed shadow of itself in such a short time, but now he was sure of one thing: this hadn't been Kacchan's doing. He had been an *idiot* to even think of that as a possibility. Kacchan had a great control over his quirk – he had mastered and perfected it from a very young age, as Izuku could very well tell. He wouldn't have used a mighty explosion right next to a freaking *bomb*, even if it was deactivated. Kacchan was a hot-head, but he wasn't stupid. Far from it.

So there *had* to be another explanation to what had happened.

Maybe Jirou had just slowed the bomb down instead of deactivating it. Maybe there had been another bomb – the destruction around him could be easily justified by more explosives that they hadn't been aware of. What he knew for sure was that this *hadn't* been caused by Kacchan's quirk.

The whole place was destroyed to pieces. It was unrecognizable. The building had *collapsed*. Not that Kacchan didn't have the power to collapse a building if he wanted to, but that was the whole point: he didn't *want* to. He had no reason to, not when there were people in there with him, even if they were villains. Not when there were still people right outside. And it couldn't have been an accident.

Because Kacchan didn't *do* accidents. Everything he did was always calculated and thought through. All Might had told Izuku that even the incident in the sewers hadn't been all that much of an incident. Kacchan had known what he was doing, he had thought about it before

acting. He had no way of knowing he would lose his hearing in the process, but he had known there would be consequences.

I knew exactly what I was doing.

And, as Izuku had freaked out over earlier, he was already under risk of being expelled. He wouldn't allow that risk to become a reality by using his quirk on a group of villains that had already been subdued and restrained. He wouldn't just blow up a whole building, neither by accident nor on purpose. So something else must have happened. Something no one other than Kacchan would be able to explain in detail, which was why Izuku would find him. *Alive.*

And, in case this had *really* been a result of Kacchan's quirk, if he had *really* caused all this… that villain down there at the deposit had said the building's structure had been rushed by the State. Which meant *anything* could have caused it to collapse. Right? So Kacchan didn't bear all of the blame. Maybe he was forced to use his quirk on one of the villains, and then… He… He didn't…

Oh god, Izuku thought, horrified. *The villains at the deposit*. Had they made it out before the building came down? Or were they stuck down there still, crushed by eleven-floors-worth of debris? That was a horrible way to die, and Izuku wouldn't wish that on anyone. He had expected those villains to answer to justice, not to death. The same went for the villains who had been with Kacchan on the 11th floor.

Was there even hope for them if they *were* down there?

Was there hope for Kacchan?

"Kacchan!", Izuku called again, louder, as if to compensate for his shirt muffling his voice. He could worry about the outcome of the collapse and what it would mean for Kacchan's future as a hero later, when Kacchan was safe and sound.

He pushed yet another large piece of concrete away in his search for the boy, sweat covering his face and his neck. His eyes were stinging from the mist of dust and smoke surrounding him; the tips of his fingers were throbbing and bleeding from the effort of climbing and pulling and pushing so much weight. His concussion was the last topic on his list of concerns on that moment, but his head was starting to pound again. Not that he paid the pain any mind.

The stiffness and the paralysis that had been ailing him just mere moments ago seemed like memories from another lifetime, even if he was still trembling and shaking. But he kept going, despite everything. He wasn't about to give up.

"*Kacchan!*"

He continued to push concrete aside, move across the debris, and lift pieces of metal away as best as he could in those conditions. He could feel as his knees became wobbly and his legs threatened to give up holding his weight, but he forced himself to continue, all the while thinking about what rubble he should and shouldn't move to preserve his and Kacchan's safety.

“Kacchan!”, he screamed, his voice becoming more desperate and guttural with each call. “Kacchan!”

How could he have done that? How had he just lied there doing nothing while Kacchan was buried beneath a *building*? How had he simply assumed Kacchan was fine? Izuku knew Kacchan was awesome, but he had been so blinded by his trust in his ability that he hadn’t even considered the possibility of worrying about him, because who else could come unscathed of an explosion if not Kacchan? And now – and now –

“Kacchan!”, Izuku wailed, the name coming out as a sob. “*K-Kacchaaaan*!”

This couldn’t be true, could it? This had to be a nightmare. Kacchan *had* to be alive. He had to be there somewhere… He had to be. Why wasn’t he able to find him? Why was he so out of reach?

“K-Kacchan”, Izuku half-sobbed, half-screamed, desperation starting to take the best of him. *What would All Might do What would All Might do What would All Might do* – “K-Kacchan, make a n-noise if you can hear me –“

He fell to his knees as his body was overcome by a rough coughing fit. There was too much dust on his air canal for him to breathe properly, and he choked and gasped as he tried to catch his breath. Low whines came out of his throat despite his best efforts to hold them back, and then the weight of what had happened finally dawned on him.

Kacchan had been inside the building when it collapsed. Kacchan was buried beneath the rubble. And Kacchan was amazing and *sugoi* and everything Izuku had always admired, but he was still only human. A human, trapped beneath the rubble of a destroyed 11-story building.

He broke.

Everything was clear as day, now. Why they had heard a primary explosion and saw Sero and Mina and Jirou and the other person being launched out before the real explosion and the collapse. Kacchan had predicted something bad was about to happen, because he was *sugoi,* and he had saved his friends first.

Izuku couldn’t figure out, for the life of him, why Kacchan hadn’t saved himself in the process.

The knowledge that Kacchan had prioritized his friends’ safety was what made everything worse. Izuku knew a lot of people questioned Kacchan’s hero potential – even the League of Villains had deemed him a worthy candidate to be an evil-doer. And yes, Kacchan had his own personal issues. He was snappy, and aggressive, and sometimes a bit too down-to-earth. Back in school, when he wasn’t bullying Izuku or being mean to him, he was ignoring him and turning a blind eye when other kids picked on him. The very origin of Izuku’s hero name was a mean nickname Kacchan gave him, meant to mock him for his helplessness.

But despite all that, despite *everything* they had gone through, even during the past months – despite Kacchan calling him quirkless in the park, despite Kacchan giving him mixed signals

and being overall very mean to him, Izuku had always known that Kacchan was, deep down in his core, a hero.

He was talented, and he was arrogant, and he usually wasn't a very good team player, but he was also someone who dedicated a lot of time into perfecting his abilities. Izuku knew, even from his ever-constant distance from Kacchan, that he was getting better at working with others. He was getting better at caring for people, even with the whole… *incident* between them.

That was what had always frustrated Izuku the most. Kacchan could always find a way to perfect himself in relation to everything – his friendship with Kirishima and Jirou was proof of that. The only thing that never seemed to change… was his relationship with Izuku.

They were always either fighting or ignoring each other. And it was tiresome, and hurtful, and toxic. Their scarce little moments of comradery never seemed to last for too long before Kacchan did something confusing or downright mean. And Izuku had put up with that for most of his life, until he couldn't anymore.

Because he loved Kacchan. He really did. He was his image of victory; he was the All Might he had access to. And yes, he could be rude, and mean, and sometimes even unnecessarily cruel, but he was also undeniably awesome. He was *incredible*. And Izuku admired him for that – for his will that never faltered, for his strength that never yielded, for his determination that never relented. For the way he was certain he would always win, and for the way he always did.

As for his flaws… Izuku had given him an ultimatum. And it had pushed them apart. Because yes, he had grown and matured enough to realize that he didn't deserve the way Kacchan treated him most of the time. That just because Kacchan gave him attention sometimes and was starting to be a bit gentler, it didn't make up for the times he was still harsh and downright cruel for no reason. That just because he loved Kacchan, it didn't mean he should allow himself to be stepped on.

Recognizing all that didn't mean Izuku was a weakling. It didn't mean he was a crybaby, or pathetic, or any of that. It meant he was *human*.

It meant he was finally respecting his own limits and sparing some thought to his own well-being, like Kacchan always told him to do. It meant he had finally come to terms with the fact that he didn't deserve to be someone's doormat all the time, no matter how much he loved that person. No matter how much that person claimed to care about him. No one should be made to feel like crap by someone they love and just accept it. *No one.* And establishing boundaries wasn't a sign of weakness, it was a sign of self-respect. Maybe he couldn't stop himself from rushing into danger when there were lives at stake just yet, but he could try to look after himself in other ways.

And yes, Kacchan acted like that to everyone. It was part of his personality. Izuku would never want – or demand – for him to change. But, just as everything else between the two of them, things were *different* when it came to Izuku. Not because he deemed himself deserving of special treatment from Kacchan or because he thought himself to be special, but because of the *weight* behind Kacchan's each and every word directed towards him.

Kirishima had never been quirkless. Kaminari, Sero, Mina, Jirou – *none* of them had ever been quirkless. They didn't know what it was like – they didn't know the weight of being born with no powers in a society like theirs.

They didn't know what it was like to be seen as useless from age 5.

They didn't know what it was like to have someone they admired tell them to kill themselves because of something they couldn't change.

And yes, yes, Izuku was over that whole "jump off the roof" thing. If anything, he had been more concerned about the consequences for Kacchan than about the possibility he would actually be coerced do it – which he knew he wouldn't. But as much as he had forgiven Kacchan for it, it didn't change the fact that it *had* happened – and the whole event was pretty much the epitome of Izuku's growing-up experience with Kacchan. Alternating between being ignored and being put down, even if he never allowed either to get the best of him.

But at the end of the day, the way Kacchan acted – even if that was just how he acted with everyone – still hit differently when it was aimed at Izuku. And while most things he did could be easily ignored or perceived as his harsh personality, *some* things still hit too close to home.

Kacchan calling Kirishima useless wasn't the same as him calling Izuku useless, because, to him, Kirishima had never been a *deku.*

And Izuku didn't want Kacchan to change. Far from it. That had never been the point. If anything, he was even a bit amused by Kacchan's hot-head antics. His competitiveness could be sort of endearing, sometimes. What Izuku wanted – what he wished for – was for Kacchan not to be such an *ass* all the time, especially during a time period when Izuku didn't have his damn *memories* to help him at least make some sense of what was happening. And on the top of being confused all the time, he was struggling to regain all the muscle mass he had lost. He was struggling to deal with the fact that he was quirkless again. He was struggling to deal with the fact that he had spent an entire month as a ghost and that he had *died* on a medical table for a moment.

He had a lot on his plate. He had a lot he didn't remember, a lot to figure out on his own. Having Kacchan yell at him for no reason right after being uncharacteristically gentle (which, on its own, was already confusing) was certainly not helping.

And having Kacchan call him quirkless despite that being Izuku's sole request was what finally made him draw the line.

So he had put his distance, at least until he recovered completely. Until he was back in an emotional state that allowed him to properly discuss everything with Kacchan, from his feelings to his lost memories.

But even from afar, Izuku could see how much Kacchan had improved.

He got along well with his friends, despite his tough-love personality. After he started anger management, he became a *little* less snappy. He seemed more thoughtful for others' well-

beings – the way he had rushed to check on Jirou and seemed concerned for Kaminari down at the deposit were ultimate proof of that.

So maybe the problem was with Kacchan, but only when it came to Izuku. Maybe they weren't meant to be friends, or close, or intimate. Maybe all they were meant to be was acquaintances, former childhood friends, former… everything. *Rivals.* Maybe they were only meant to be rivals, and nothing else.

Maybe all Kacchan was meant to feel for Izuku was either annoyance or indifference.

And putting distance between them made Izuku's heart ache, but being close to Kacchan and hurt by him was more painful. He had endured it in the past, but in the past, Kacchan's friendship with Kirishima hadn't been there to create such a stark contrast.

In the past, his easy and fast proximity to Jirou hadn't been there to make Izuku wonder what he had been doing wrong all these years. And in the past, he had been a needy, friendless, quirkless boy who nevertheless admired Kacchan, and who therefore allowed himself to be treated badly because it was better to have this type of interaction with him than to have no interaction at all.

But he was no longer that boy. He had changed.

And so had Kacchan.

This was why, after all their discussions and arguments in the museum, Izuku had been hoping to talk things out with Kacchan. Properly, this time. It would be hard to go through it without screaming and yelling as they always did, but they would have to do it.

Well. Izuku *needed* to do it. He needed to lay his heart out to Kacchan and tell him everything he felt and thought. He needed to tell him how much he had missed him during those months, and how much he wanted to understand. Understand why they had grown apart over the years, understand why they *couldn't* understand each other.

He needed to *talk* to Kacchan. He needed to figure out if they had a future as friends, or if he had been right to distance himself.

But more than all that, he needed Kacchan to be alive. Even if they never became friends.

Because Izuku would still love Kacchan, even from afar, even if they were nothing but rivals. It had always been like that. Maybe he wouldn't allow Kacchan to belittle him anymore, but he would still love him. He would still worry about him, and care about him, and… and…

He couldn't lose Kacchan. Life without him was… unimaginable.

"Kacchan!", he called out again once his coughing went down, voice raspy. "Kacchan!"

Kacchan had always been there. To lose him – to know one of the last interactions he ever had with him was yet another fight – would be unbearable. Izuku couldn't let that happen.

He would never be able to call himself a hero if Kacchan died. He would never be able to call himself a hero if he couldn't save one of the people who mattered the most to him.

"Don't – D-Don't *do* this, Kacchan", Izuku grunted angrily, going back to pushing concrete and girders and debris. He was panting and trembling all over from the strain his body was under, since the weight he was dislodging was immense and he *did* have a concussion still, but he couldn't give up. No pro was anywhere in sight and Izuku didn't know what the hell was taking them so long, but he was the only one who could help Kacchan so far and he would be damned if he didn't.

And he *was* angry. And, again, maybe he could understand Kacchan's past breakdowns a little bit better, now. If just the idea of having Kacchan die on him was so excruciating, Izuku couldn't imagine what it would feel like if he had to watch that happen firsthand. *Twice*.

"Make a noise if you can hear me, Kacchan", Izuku continued to plead, pant, grunt. His muscles ached so bad, but he couldn't stop. "Make – a n-noise", he said through gritted teeth, pushing a heavy block of concrete to the side. "I-If you can – if you can – h-hear me –", he groaned.

He settled the concrete aside, revealing a gap amidst the debris. It was a hole of some sorts, the entrance to a pocket of air formed by what had probably been the 11th floor of the building and the ceiling that collapsed above it.

Izuku tried to see what was inside the pocket, but it was too dark.

"Kacchan?", he shouted at the hole, squinting his eyes. "Kacchan, are you down there?"

No reply came other than the echo of his own voice, but it wasn't like he had been getting any response so far.

Izuku glanced upwards, at the light-pink sky above him. Some of the dust from the collapse had settled down, but there was still a beige mist surrounding him – making it hard to breathe – along with a black trail of smoke that stood out against the sky. The sun was starting to set, which meant it would be dark soon. They needed to get Kacchan out of there as soon as possible, especially if he needed medical help.

From what Izuku had overheard while he was at the makeshift medbay outside, Kacchan was the only person trapped here. From Iida's words, and from the unknown paramedic's shouted orders, he could imply that everyone else was safe – or at least not buried beneath rubble. Which meant Kacchan was the only person he needed to worry about for the time being. The only person on which he should focus his attention.

Well… Kacchan, and himself. Because if he accidentally got hurt due to his recklessness or his rush, he wouldn't be able to help. He knew that better than anyone, flashbacks of his floppy broken arms flailing behind him as he launched himself towards Kacchan appearing in his mind. And just like on that day at the Training Camp, Kacchan could use Izuku's assistance, even if he would never admit it.

But if Izuku climbed down into that hole, there was a high chance the debris around it would collapse because of his weight shifting them, sealing him inside.

Izuku took a deep breath, trying to figure out what he should do.

There was a chance Kacchan wasn't down there, and if he got sealed inside, he would waste his opportunity to rescue him. There was also a chance Kacchan *was* down there, and if they did get sealed, at least Izuku would be able to help him stay alive until proper help arrived.

(There was a chance Kacchan was down there and wasn't responding because he was already dead, but Izuku simply refused to take that possibility into consideration.)

"Kacchan!", Izuku shouted again, growing desperate. His breaths were coming out as harsh puffs, his hands trembling violently. "Are you down there? Can you hear me?"

And then – he heard something.

It couldn't have been more than a whisper. Barely audible from where he was standing, but his ears were so sharpened in their desperate attempts to detect *anything* that could indicate Kacchan was there that he didn't miss it.

(Maybe it was just his mind playing tricks on him, trying to convince him that the risk of going down there was better than the risk of never finding Kacchan.)

Something flickered inside the pocket, drawing his attention – orange, dancing and casting shadows in the dark.

Fire.

If Kacchan really was down there… he could be burned any minute now. He could *suffocate.*

There was a feeling deep in his gut that told him that he needed to get down there.

Izuku decided to take his chance.

He lied down on the debris, throwing his legs inside the hole on the floor first while he supported his upper body on a piece of concrete that seemed to be the steadiest on the rim of the pocket. His legs dangled in the air beneath him, not finding anything to support themselves.

The hole hadn't seemed too deep, but Izuku couldn't risk twisting an ankle or hurting himself further if he fell in a wrong angle. So he carefully slid his weight down, heart thumping madly inside his chest, until his arms were completely stretched as he hung from his hands holding the concrete. The rubble started to shift a bit to the side at the weight disruption.

Pebbles rained down into Izuku's blood-matted hair. With a grimace, he craned his neck to look down, seeing that there was a large block of concrete just two meters beneath him that could soften his fall. He could aim for that block and slide the rest of the way down without risking bringing the whole thing down above himself and Kacchan – if he really was down there.

Izuku closed his eyes again, taking a deep breath and calculating the angle in which he should fall to preserve his ankles, his knees, and his back. Once he was sure he would fall right, he let go.

Thankfully, he didn't break or twist anything when he collapsed against the block of concrete with an *oof*, but the impact was still painful on his already abused limbs. He paid it no mind, however, as he resumed sliding down and quickly got to his feet as soon as he found a flat, steady surface to thread on.

A few pebbles rained down after him from the hole above him, but the structure remained firm. It didn't collapse or seal him inside the pocket, which was a small miracle he could be thankful for.

Now that he was down there, he could see things more clearly, thanks to the pink light coming from the sunset outside and from the fire raging on the corner. The fire didn't seem to be too concerning so far, orange sparkling bright but otherwise barely spreading any warmth to where Izuku was standing – yet. The smoke it was producing wasn't too substantial, and most of it was currently dissipating through the hole Izuku had opened. However, he knew it was just a matter of time before the flames spread on towards him, which meant there was no time for slacking around.

He spun on his heels, eyes searching the dim-lit pocket for any signs of Kacchan. Debris, broken chairs, rubble and concrete painted the scenario around him, and it became clear to him that the floor of the 11th level had collapsed inwards when the building came down. The girders that formed the building's structure still stood tall, like a metal skeleton mocking him, but everything else had sunken to form the crater Izuku had climbed up and down. The ceiling of the building had crashed into the 11th floor, but some of the columns had remained steady enough to support large, askew chunks of concrete, which had resulted in the pocket Izuku was currently in.

"Kacchan?", he called, his voice echoing across the pocket sinisterly.

The air in there was cold and mushy despite the fire; the miasma of dust, smoke and destruction making it even harder for him to breathe.

"You t-too? *M-Minna*?", Izuku heard a too-familiar voice ask, the sound barely above a choked-out whisper.

Izuku's heart dropped and he swallowed dry.

Kacchan's voice sounded raspy and weak, something Izuku had definitely never witnessed before in his entire life – which was saying a lot, since Izuku knew him ever since he could *freaking remember*. Kacchan was always loud and fierce and booming – never that soft, never that *weak.*

It sent an unpleasant shiver of dread down Izuku's spine.

"Kacchan?", he called again, voice small from fear, walking slowly towards the source of the sound.

Walking inside this pocket was like walking in a landmine, more so than it had been up above – any wrong step could cause the whole structure to collapse even further, but now there was also a faux ceiling that could smash him like an insect if it crashed. His heart begged him to move faster, to get to Kacchan at once, but he knew he needed to be careful if he wanted to rescue his friend.

"Ok", he heard Kacchan say, and – was that relief in his voice? "O-Ok".

Izuku let out a shaky breath.

"Kacchan?", he called again, his whole body feeling cold and stiff from fear as he moved carefully, taking one considerate slow step after the other. He felt like he was a child playing 'the floor is lava', carefully thinking about where to jump at before he made a move, lest his rush and his mistake doom him. "Kacchan, I'm right here, ok? I'm coming for you".

No response came, and the silence drove Izuku to the brink of insanity.

When he finally got to where he thought Kacchan was at, he didn't spot the boy right away. He looked around desperately, trying to convince himself that he hadn't lost his sanity and that he had *actually* heard Kacchan's voice coming from that direction.

Until he found it.

A sparkle of crimson. Glassy. Sightless.

It was Kacchan's eye. The rest of his face – the rest of his *body* – was completely buried under the rubble directly beneath Izuku's feet.

Izuku was standing over him.

Izuku just stared at him for a moment, frozen on the spot, trying to convince himself that this was real and that he wasn't imagining it.

Because Kacchan looked dead.

"Oh my god!", Izuku jumped to the side lest he crush Kacchan even further when his penny finally dropped, his voice coming out almost like a whimper. "K-Kacchan?!"

He realized he had never felt this much fear before in his life, not even in Kamino. Kacchan's eye didn't move, it didn't even blink. And Izuku couldn't breathe.

Am I too late? Am I too late?

He fell to his knees, immediately working on removing the first piece of concrete – the one that was blocking Kacchan's face from view. He set the heavy block aside with a grunt, but Kacchan didn't stir or even acknowledge his presence at all – and once his face was uncovered, Izuku realized his other eye was swollen completely shut, an ugly shade of purple.

There was blood matted on Kacchan's forehead and hair, dust covering the rest of his skin. There were also burn marks on his cheeks, chin, and neck – probably a result of the explosion. It was impossible for Izuku to tell if they would leave a scar, the blistered wounds a mixture of red and black.

Izuku's breaths came out in the form of short puffs. Kacchan's open eye was half-lidded and almost closed all the way; his lips parted slightly. He seemed to be completely unresponsive, and on the brink of completely losing his consciousness.

"K-Kacchan", Izuku said, voice trembling so hard his words were barely comprehensible. "D-Don't pass out just yet".

Kacchan did nothing.

"Can you hear me? Kacchan?", he asked, his breaths coming out as short, small puffs of air. He was aware he was verging on hyperventilating, but who could blame him? Kacchan looked like a corpse. Like a *corpse.* "I'll get you out. Ok?", he continued, trying to keep his cool. "Complain about it all you want later, but I'll – I'll get you out".

Kacchan continued to lay there, his one open eye staring at nothing with a glassy look.

Oh god, he looked dead. The injuries on his face and forehead seemed superficial, but Izuku could see the dark stain of red blood pooling beneath the back of his head. Who knew what other injuries were hidden beneath all that concrete?!

Izuku needed to get him out of there *stat.* If Kacchan's so far lack of reaction was any indicator, they couldn't afford waiting for help to arrive. Izuku would need to drag *him* to help. And he couldn't do that if Kacchan was pinned beneath the rubble.

The next block Izuku moved was the one covering the upper half of Kacchan's body. On one hand, Izuku was glad he moved the block of concrete, because that finally – *finally* – earned a reaction from the so far unresponsive Kacchan.

On the other hand, Izuku wished he hadn't moved it, because the reaction was it earned was pain.

Because Kacchan had been impaled.

Izuku stared in shock at the huge piece of metal protruding from the left side of Kacchan's lower abdomen. The metal was tinged dark red, and blood was oozing slowly from the gruesome wound to pool on the rubble supporting Kacchan's back. With each weak, shuddering breath Kacchan took, a new trail of blood emerged.

All Izuku did for a moment was stare. Removing the concrete from atop the injury had clearly also removed the pressure that was keeping the blood from flowing out.

Had Izuku just signed Kacchan's death warrant?

The blood dropped from Izuku's face to his stomach so fast, he was sure he was about to pass out. He had seen a lot of gruesome injuries in his short training as a hero, but none – none of

them had been inflicted on Kacchan.

Kacchan, who was lying very still, his one good eye still glassy and sightless. Kacchan, who was now frowning slightly in pain, as if very confused as to what was happening to him. Kacchan, whose breaths were coming off so short and shallow Izuku could barely notice the tiny movements of his chest.

Kacchan, who was starting to bleed out because Izuku had removed the *damn pressure*.

“Ok”, Izuku sighed out, his voice shaking way too much. “O-Ok, ok, I’ve – I’ve got you. I’ve got you, Kacchan”, he forced the words out, wasting no time in removing his own shirt and immediately rolling it into a ball. He needed to stop the blood from flowing out too fast, or Kacchan would go into shock.

He placed the rolled-up shirt against the injury, applying pressure.

He had honestly been expecting a yell, or a loud shout of pain, or a curse, or even a command to “fucking stop that, you damn nerd, that hurts like shit!”.

What he got instead was a tiny, breathy whimper.

Oh my god. Oh my god, Kacchan, oh my god.

Tears were rolling down Izuku’s face as he continued to apply pressure to Kacchan’s injury. His plan to drag Kacchan out of there was impossible to accomplish, now. He couldn’t remove the piece of metal impaling him, otherwise Kacchan would only bleed out faster – probably way too fast for Izuku to get him help in time. He didn’t know if the metal had struck something major or nicked an artery, so he couldn’t be sure he wouldn’t kill Kacchan for sure if he moved him.

“K-K-Kacchan”, Izuku stuttered, sniffing. Kacchan’s face was titled slightly away from him, his glassy eye fixed on the pink sky above them through the small opening Izuku had created to climb down into the pocket.

Izuku gently reached out with one blood-covered hand and palmed Kacchan’s face as tenderly as he could, tilting it towards himself. When he retrieved his hand in order to keep applying pressure to the injury, he noticed that his bloody handprint had marked Kacchan’s dusty face, contrasting starkly with its paleness and with the whiteness from all the dust.

Kacchan blinked at him, but his face was vacant from recognition, still blank and completely emotionless apart from the tiny frown between his eyebrows. Izuku noticed with a twist of horror that a tear track had slid from Kacchan’s good eye, washing away a line of dust from his skin all the way down to his temple.

“H-Hey”, Izuku forced himself to smile, even though there were several fat tears rolling down his cheeks. He sniffed, trying to clean away some of the mess by rubbing his nose on his shoulder. His hands never stopped pressing down on Kacchan’s injury. “Hey, Kacchan. Can you hear me?”, he asked, voice wobbly.

His forced smile faltered easily when Kacchan did nothing other than stare at him, face vacant. His glassy eye darted a bit across Izuku's face, slow, as if he was trying to analyze his features and recognize him.

Izuku held back a sob. He had never seen Kacchan this disoriented, or weak, or… or…

Then, Izuku finally noticed. Kacchan's hearing aid was nowhere to be seen, probably broken beyond repair when the building collapsed.

Kacchan couldn't hear him.

Well, he *should* be able to hear him with his functioning ear, but he clearly wasn't doing so on the moment. Izuku couldn't blame him – he had been right there when the explosion happened, so it was probable that his good ear was still ringing from the loud blast. Izuku had experienced the same thing, and he had been all the way down there – he could only assume the ringing would be worse on Kacchan's already impaired ears, since he had been right there, in the ground zero.

Izuku desperately tried to convince himself that Kacchan's good ear was only *ringing* for the time being, because he didn't really want to think about the *other* possibility. After all, when Kacchan lost his hearing in his other ear, the cause had also been a strong explosion.

Izuku did his best not to think about what that would mean for Kacchan's future as a hero. He was sure that Kacchan would figure it out, because he was amazing. He wasn't the type of person who allowed difficulties to stand on his way, and with the proper equipment, Izuku was sure he would find a way to carry on his journey towards the top, even if his hearing was impaired.

But what if his hearing is too damaged? What if not even a hearing aid fixes it this time? What if Recovery Girl can't make it right, what if he never hears anything ever again? Will he still be able to be a hero, then? Will he be allowed? Were there disabled heroes? Could there be? Where was the line drawn, how much would a hearing impairment affect Kacchan's odds?

Ok, he was back to panicking again and he needed to focus on one problem at the time. His priority had to be keeping Kacchan alive until help arrived – everything else could be thought about later. There was nothing he could do for Kacchan's hearing right now. Kacchan's head, on the other hand, was still bleeding. *A lot.* And head injuries were always terrible when it came to blood-losing speed, so that was something Izuku could try to fix.

"Ok, o-ok", Izuku said, breathing hard and trying to figure out what to do. He looked around, searching for anything he could use, but he came up empty.

He let out a breathy sigh and closed his eyes for a brief moment before realizing he had no other option. He retrieved his shirt from Kacchan's injury, finding a piece of the fabric that hadn't been drenched in blood yet. Then, using a lot of strength, he ripped the piece away, a bit of his heart tearing along with it.

He had really loved the shirt. He wished he didn't have to ruin it. He really hoped Kacchan wouldn't be sad or offended that Izuku was tearing his birthday gift to pieces, but he didn't really have any other choice. And he'd rather keep Kacchan alive to yell at him for ruining his present than to have him die over his fondness for a shirt.

I'd rather have you spend the rest of your shitty days mad at me then having you die.

He folded the piece of cloth he cut out as well as he could before leaning over Kacchan's still body. His rough, scarred hand gently cradled Kacchan's head up while the other hand placed the folded cloth against the gash on the back of his skull.

Kacchan moaned low down his throat, his teeth immediately gritting in pain. His weak breaths came out faster because of the agony he was feeling, and as Izuku tenderly placed his head back down on the concrete, the cloth pressed closely against the wound, Kacchan's eye rolled in its socket and his face went completely slack, any traces of pain disappearing completely from it.

He had passed out.

"Hey, no", Izuku said, urgent, slapping his free hand on Kacchan's face while his other hand went back to pressing his ruined shirt on the impalement injury. "Kacchan. No sleeping, ok? Help is almost here, so you need to stay awake, ok?"

The insistent slapping earned no result for a while, until Kacchan's good eye fluttered open again, staring at nothing before darting around to find Izuku's face.

He frowned in pain, which, in a moment like that, was a good sign, even if it broke Izuku's heart. At least he wasn't completely out of it – at least he could still feel something. Feeling things meant he was still alive. And he had to stay that way.

"S-Stay with me, ok?", Izuku pleaded, his voice still too shaky and wobbly. He was fighting against his tears as best as he could, because this wasn't the moment to break down. He needed to stay strong for Kacchan. "You have to stay awake", he added. "Just a while longer".

Kacchan continued to stare at him, as if Izuku had just spoken a completely different language that he couldn't comprehend.

"D-D– … D–", he attempted, but the words didn't come out. His breathing was so slow and shallow that Izuku found it a miracle he even managed to stutter.

"Shh, don't try to talk", Izuku instructed, putting on his fake smile once again. "You're ok. Just a bit battered. But that's being taken care of, all right? Just stay down, don't speak, and don't fall asleep".

Kacchan continued to stare at him with glassy eyes and a frown, swallowing drily a few times.

"D-D-De… k-ku?", he managed, completely ignoring everything Izuku had just said.

Izuku breathed out shakily.

“Yes, it’s me, Kacchan”, he nodded, his smile faltering a bit before he forced it back on. “Don’t try to talk, all right?”

Kacchan narrowed his one good eye at him, seeming in pain and confused.

“C-C-Can’t… H-Hear… Y-Y-Y–…“, he gasped, swallowing dry several times again. He wheezed weakly, never finishing the sentence.

Kacchan tried to shift positions, which obviously disrupted the metal impaling him. He squeezed his eye shut in agony, whimpering breathily again.

“Hey, hey, it’s ok, it’s ok”, Izuku said, cupping Kacchan’s face with one hand while the other continued to apply pressure to the injury. That seemed to calm him down a bit, since he relaxed on Izuku’s hold. “Everything is fine, Kacchan. Just don’t move, ok?”

Kacchan continued to stare at him, confused and dazed. He let out a breathy noise that could have been a whimper or a groan, but didn’t have enough strength in it to be anything other than a little deaf whistle of air.

Fine, ok. So Kacchan couldn’t hear him and one of his eyes was swollen shut. The vision in his good eye was probably compromised as well, which meant he couldn’t hear him *or* read his lips. And he had no idea what was happening to him, if he thought moving was a good idea.

Izuku took a deep breath, biting at his lower lip. He removed his hand from Kacchan’s face and tried to use sign language with only one hand. He exaggerated his movements so that Kacchan could read into them even if his vision was blurry or doubled.

“*Everything is fine*”, he signed slowly. “*You’re a bit hurt, but you’ll be all right. Help is almost here, so you can’t go to sleep, ok?*”

Kacchan stared at him blankly for a few moments. It took him nearly half a minute to comprehend what Izuku was telling him and respond.

“’K-Kay”, he grunted out.

Izuku breathed out in relief, nodding and going back to applying pressure to the injury with both hands.

This Kacchan was completely different from the Kacchan he had known his whole life. He was compliant, and soft, and weakened. He wasn’t lashing out at Izuku for giving him orders, he wasn’t trying to keep a strong façade, he wasn’t even calling Izuku names. It was obvious that he was giving everything he had to fight unconsciousness and stay awake per Izuku’s request, but there was no light in his one open eye. No determination. Just a troubling hint of confusion mixed with pain, as if he wasn’t really sure why he needed to do as he was told but felt too weak to question it.

It scared Izuku.

Seeing Kacchan like that was downright terrifying, and the fact that the lower half of his body, as well as both his arms, were still buried beneath the rubble only made everything worse. Izuku *could* attempt to remove the concrete pinning Kacchan's arms down so that he would at least be able to use sign language instead of speaking, but he was sincerely afraid he would only end up uncovering yet another injury that could end up bleeding out.

He only had two hands – if Kacchan started losing blood from more than one place at once, he wouldn't be able to stop the flow, and there wouldn't be enough time to move him all the way out of the wreckage and back towards the ambulances before he bled out. Plus, Izuku figured speaking would cost Kacchan less energy than moving his arms around to communicate – he wasn't even sure Kacchan *could* move much more than his head on the moment.

"H-H-Hey, D-D-D–", Kacchan tried to speak again, not quite managing to pronounce the name.

"Yes", Izuku nodded, but then remembered Kacchan couldn't hear him. He kept pressure on the wound with only one hand again so that he could raise the other to sign: "*I'm right here*".

Kacchan opened and closed his mouth a few times, as if trying to remember the words he wanted to use. He was looking at something right beside Izuku's head, his eye not quite focusing on his face.

"I – I t-think – I t-think t-t-th– m' a-arms –", he stuttered out, voice small and breathless. His pained frown intensified. "M'arms're… b-b-brok'n…?"

Izuku frowned at him. He looked down at the rest of Kacchan's covered body – his arms and legs weren't visible beneath the rubble. But Izuku wouldn't doubt they were broken – it would be a miracle if they weren't, given everything that had happened.

He smiled back at Kacchan, giving his shoulder a reassuring squeeze before raising his hand at his eyelevel once again.

"*Your arms will be fine. Don't worry about them*", he signed, slow and clear.

It still took Kacchan longer than usual to comprehend the phrase.

"Y-Y-Ya sur'?", he frowned eventually, his good eye trying – and failing – to focus on Izuku's face. "I n-n-need'em".

"*I know you do*", Izuku signed, failing to hold back a sob and sniffing quickly as if to muffle the sound – not that Kacchan could hear it, anyway. "*But trust me, they will be fine. So will you*".

Kacchan frowned, and, once the delayed time of his comprehension passed, he craned his head to look around.

"Nee' m'arms. An' m-my… h-h-han…ds…", he groaned, growing frantic. Izuku's reassurance had no effect on him, apparently, and his one good eye widened slightly in terror.

“M’han’s’re… s-smash’d. M’hands’re smash’d”, he realized, trying to wriggle himself free and immediately grunting in pain as his injury was once again disrupted.

“*Kacchan, please, stand down*”, Izuku signed nervously, trying to press on his shoulder to hold him in place, *and* sign, *and* keep pressure on the wound, all at the same time. “*Your hands are ok*”, he intercalated signing and holding Kacchan down.

“N-Nee’ m’hands, Dek’”, he groaned, still wiggling weakly. “Nee’em”.

“*Your hands are fine*”, Izuku signed again, nervous.

He winced in sympathy when Kacchan’s only response was a low moan of pain.

“*Please, stay still, Kacchan*”, he cradled Kacchan’s face again, turning it towards him. “*Don’t you trust me?*”, he signed, right before caressing Kacchan’s cheek with his thumb.

Kacchan stared at him without replying, but he went still and stopped struggling.

Izuku let out a sigh of relief. The sentiment was short lived, however, since Kacchan frowned and craned his neck again, eye searching for something amidst the wreckage.

“Y-Y-Ya g’tta f-find ‘tsume”, he grunted out, seeming distressed, as if he had just remembered something very important. The movement disrupted his injury once more, and Izuku felt, with a twist in his chest, as more warm blood flowed through his fingers from the hole in Kacchan’s stomach. He placed his other hand against the injury again, trying to stench the flow of blood as well as he could.

God, so the fourth person to be launched out had been *Hatsume*? Was that why she had been in such pain, in such desperation? Had Kacchan really sacrificed himself so he could save her life?

“Shh, shh”, Izuku soothed desperately, but it was useless – Kacchan didn’t hear it. And Izuku couldn’t keep removing his hand from the injury just to caress Kacchan’s face all the time – he needed to keep applying pressure. Instead, he leaned a bit over Kacchan, nudging his nose against his shoulder to call his attention, like a cat would.

Kacchan’s eye found him, but it was still glassy. He gasped weekly, spasming, and seemingly choking on something.

His breathing made it sound like he was drowning in mud. Izuku desperately wished that someone – anyone – would appear and tell him what to do. He briefly removed one of his hands from the injury so he could sign.

“*You don’t have to worry. Everyone is safe. You got everyone out. You’re sugoi, Kacchan*”, he added the last bit in the hope that the praise would help him calm down, immediately going back to pressing down on the wound.

Kacchan simply stared at him.

“E’en ‘tsume?”, he slurred, frowning.

Izuku nodded vehemently so that Kacchan could see it.

Kacchan blinked sluggishly, still tense.

“E’en D’ku?”

Izuku bit his lower lip, holding back another sob. His eyes were pooling with fresh tears.

He nodded again.

Once he understood the message, Kacchan relaxed beneath him, his head going limp and rolling a bit to the side as he stared off at the distance.

“’Kay”, he groaned softly, voice barely audible.

“*What did I tell you, huh?*”, Izuku signed desperately, putting a special effort on making sure his hands were in Kacchan’s direct line of sight. “*No sleeping, Kacchan. Please?*”

Kacchan didn’t respond, simply laying there with his eye open and unseeing, his breathing becoming shallower with each passing second.

Izuku started to hyperventilate again. He was about to lose it, he could tell.

There was only one thing he could think of that would make Kacchan stay awake. And maybe it was a bit cruel, but it was better than having him die on him. He wasn’t even sure that it was going to work, but given everything they had gone through in the past months – given the way Kacchan had reacted in the park, and in the deposit…

It was worth a try. He was desperate enough to try anything, really.

Here goes nothing.

“*Hey, I was wrong*”, he signed. “*Deku isn’t safe. He’s still in danger*”.

No reaction. Kacchan simply lied there, indifferent to the rest of the world, eyes glazed.

Izuku breathed shakily and poked Kacchan’s shoulder, trying to catch his attention.

“*Hey, Kacchan*”, he signed again. “*You got that? Deku is in danger*”.

It took Kacchan a while before he blinked and frowned slightly. He still didn’t move his head, but at least he reacted.

“*He said he’s going to surpass you as number one hero and he ran into a wrecked building that had just exploded just so he could rescue people*”, Izuku continued, slowly and steadily – in a pace Kacchan could understand in that state.

Kacchan moved his head a bit, his one good eye darting around in confusion and disorientation.

"*So you can't go to sleep, ok? Not until Deku is out of the building safe and sound*", Izuku concluded, pressing his other hand back against the injury.

Kacchan swallowed dry, worry flooding his face.

"D-D-De… ku…", he groaned out, grimacing in pain. "I g-gotta… I – I g-got…"

"Shh", Izuku soothed him again, rubbing his face on his shoulder so that he didn't have to use his hands.

Kacchan relaxed a bit at the touch, closing his good eye briefly.

"Kacchan?", Izuku asked, raising his head to stare at Kacchan with attention. Had he passed out again? "Don't fall asleep –", he said aloud, taking a hand to squeeze Kacchan's shoulder.

Kacchan jolted back into wakefulness, gasping. He looked up at Izuku, and, for the first time since Izuku found him in the rubble, his eyes looked sober. Still a bit glassy, still confused, but there a was new life inside them.

"De… ku", he grunted, sounding like mustering every syllable was a herculean task. He was breathless, wheezing.

"*I am here*", he signed at Kacchan, before pressing down on his injury again.

Kacchan stared at him for a couple more moments, blinking his good eye sluggishly.

"I t-t-think –", he gasped, choking. "M' hands're… crush'd…"

Then Kacchan's neck relaxed and his head lolled to the side, his eye fluttering shut before his whole body went slack.

"Please…"

"Awake…"

"On…"

"Do this…"

“Kacchan…”

Katsuki opened his eyes, but only one of them obeyed.

The sky was purple. Which was weird, because it had been pink just a second ago, right before he blinked…

He tried to gather his surroundings, but it was hard. It was kind of dark, and everything was swimming around him.

Was he underwater? Was that why it was so hard to breathe?

He tried to hold his breath, since he didn’t want to swallow any water like a loser. He tried to remember where he was or what had happened, but his memory came in blank. He tried to flail his arms for impulse so that he could swim up, but he found that he couldn’t. He was stuck.

When black spots started to appear in his already blurry vision, he couldn’t hold back any longer. He gasped in a large lungful of air, but only half of it made it to his screaming lungs. It felt like there was a weight on the top of his chest, preventing it from expanding. But he wasn’t drowning, so at least there was that.

A bloodied hand appeared in front of his face, and Katsuki frowned at it. It was moving to form shapes, shapes he recognized – but he couldn’t really comprehend.

He squinted. Only one of his eyes obeyed.

Huh. Only one of his eyes was open.

He felt like he was floating. He had been floating just a minute ago, hadn’t he…? Like… Like a petal on a stream… Like…

And… someone had been there, huh? But why couldn’t he remember it? He felt really lightheaded… maybe that was why.

Fuck that, he didn’t have the time to feel lightheaded. He had something to do. If only he could remember what… What it…

The owner of the hand appeared in front of his eye, green and white and red. And weren’t green and red complementary colors? And wasn’t his color red and Izuku’s color green? Did that mean they were complementary as well?

Izuku? Where was Izuku? There was something inside his brain telling him the idiot was in danger, but he couldn’t… He didn’t really remember, and he didn’t know where he was…? Was the in danger? Where was he?

Where was Katsuki?

He tried to ask the owner of the hand as much, but his voice seemed to have abandoned him. Instead, in its place, was a brick. Or maybe… mud? Clogging his throat?

He was drowning? Underwater? What was happening?

Maybe – Maybe he should… hold his breath…? Or…?

Oh, yeah, that hadn't worked out. But whatever was happening, he needed to shrug it off and keep going. He couldn't let something silly take him down. He didn't even know what was happening, but he was fairly sure it was silly. And he wasn't weak. He wasn't about to lie there and do nothing when he could – When he could –

Hot fire erupted in his torso, spreading to his entire body. He opened his mouth to scream, but nothing came out. The pain was so scorching that he was sure he blacked out for a moment.

When his eye opened again, he was dizzy and breathing was harder. His mouth was gaping, trying to suck in shallow breaths.

There was a shape above him, but Katsuki's vision was too blurry for him to comprehend who it was. There was also a hand caressing his cheek, which felt – nice.

But he didn't have time for nice. He needed to leave. He needed – There was something he needed to do…

"Hnng", he grimaced, shivering all over as chills ran down his spine. What was happening to him? Why couldn't he see shit and why did it feel so cold? Suddenly, the hand on his face became too much for his overloaded senses and he flinched away from the touch, which hesitated and disappeared.

Then, more fire spreading across his torso. He opened his mouth again, and as he tried to suck in another painful breath, he found that he couldn't.

He tried to pull away whatever it was that was pressing down on his chest, but frowned when his hands didn't move.

Huh. That was weird. Was he stuck?

With a strength he didn't even know he still had, Katsuki lifted his head and opened the only eye that was obeying him. His vision was still too blurry, but he managed to see that there was something pinning him down – something large and heavy, covering his arms and his legs.

What the fuck. What the fuck? Where was he? Where *was he*?

"Wh's go'n on?", he slurred, his voice barely audible to his own ears. The sound was far away, muffled beneath a layer of mud and a layer of water and a layer of concrete and a layer of fire – and his ear – his only good ear, it was ringing very loudly –

"Easy, Kacchan", he thought he heard someone say, but it was so, so, so far away, so muffled by the ringing, and then a hand appeared into his line of sight. "*Easy, Kacchan*", the hand told him through sign language.

Huh. Had he heard the hand? Had he predicted what it was going to say and then heard it in his mind? But why did the voice in his head sound like Deku?

Katsuki turned his aching head to however was talking to him. He found dark green contrasting with the purple sky, beautiful emeralds shining at him. They looked so pretty.

“M’han’s”, he struggled to say the words, his chest and lungs protesting at the effort. But he needed to let the person with him know. He wouldn’t be able to get them out of there if his hands were out of commission… And he really needed his hands. For the rest of his life. He would be quirkless without them.

Quirkless… That… That reminded him of something… He had… He had to…

“M’hands’re… s-stuck…”, he groaned, trying to wriggle them free and failing.

“*I know*”, the person signed at him. “*I’m going to fix that, ok? But you need to stay still*”.

Katsuki squinted at the person. He knew that person. He… He knew… them…

“*Can you do that for me?*”, the person asked him through sign language, and Katsuki’s brain took a long while to interpret and process those signals.

Why did this person want him to keep still and do nothing? There were people he needed to help, goddamn it. The villains were attacking and Ears had been bleeding –

Oh shit.

“Ji… rou…”, Katsuki slurred, hating how weak his voice sounded but not having the energy to muster anything stronger. “Wh’re’s… S-She – w’s bleed’n…”, he wheezed, gasping.

He couldn’t support his head up any longer and let it fall back with a pathetic whimper, but the back of his skull connected with something soft. Was the person holding his head?

“*She’s fine. Everyone is fine*”, the person lowered his head down smoothly and signed at him. Katsuki wanted to grab them by the collar and pull them closer to yell at their face for some reason, but when he tried, he found he couldn’t move. Why couldn’t he move, why couldn’t he move – Was he stuck? What was happening to him?

“Why’m’I st’ck?”, he groaned, trying to move again. A wave of pain followed by dizziness invaded his senses and before he knew better, everything went black.

Izuku retrieved his hand from Kacchan's forehead.

He was burning up. Which was no surprise, since he had been literally impaled. The fever wasn't the most pressing matter compared to Kacchan's other ailments, but it did little to reassure Izuku, either.

At least it meant he was still alive. Right? His body was still putting up a fight, like it was expected of Kacchan.

He kept waking up for just a few seconds, only to pass out again. He didn't seem to be aware of where he was or of what was happening, and he was losing blood way too fast. And where the hell were those damn pros?! Izuku had thought they would have followed him in already, even with the threat of a collapse.

After Kacchan passed out for the third time, coughing brokenly, Izuku took one of his bloodied hands to his pocket. He found his phone, screen cracked beyond repair because of the pandemonium outside, but he was still able to unlock it. He tried to ignore the way his crimson thumbprint stained the screen as he tapped on it.

Even through the cracks he could see he had 13 missed calls and 10 new voicemails. Izuku swiped the notifications away, finding his contact list instead.

He placed the phone between his ear and his shoulder and waited as it rung, going back to applying pressure to Kacchan's injury with both hands.

"C'mon, c'mon, c'mon", he muttered under his breath, trying not to dwell on how burnt the skin of Kacchan's face looked, or how the puddle of blood leaking out of him was growing. He also kept coughing wetly, which Izuku tried to interpret as his body's response to the smoke of the constantly growing fire inside the pocket, but it could also mean that Kacchan's ribs –

"Midoriya, what the *hell* were you thinking –", Jirou's voice erupted in his ear, but before she could continue there was a shuffling sound and a new voice spoke up.

"You need to get out of there. The structure is about to collapse completely in a matter of minutes. That's why the pros didn't make a move yet, and why you shouldn't have. If they just rush in, all they'll do is disrupt the rubble further. They're making a plan of action to get Bakugou out as we speak".

That was Todoroki.

"I can't get out", Izuku choked out, going back to noticing how wobbly and shaky his voice sounded.

When he spoke to Kacchan, the weakness displayed in his voice didn't bother him. Now, speaking to Todoroki, the trembling tone he was emitting made shame blossom in his chest, even if he couldn't really understand the reason.

That seemed to soften Todoroki's disapproval a bit, however, because when he spoke up again, his tone was softer – but still cold.

"Did you get stuck?", he asked, concerned.

"N-No", Izuku breathed out shakily. "But I found Kacchan".

A pause.

"He – H-He was… im–imp-paled", Izuku mustered out, and somehow saying the words aloud only made everything even more horrifying. It made everything come true.

Kacchan had been impaled. Kacchan was bleeding out.

Kacchan was dying.

He found himself choking out a sob, fresh tears running down his face.

Another pause. Longer this time.

Then, more shuffling.

And the voice that greeted Izuku made his heart break all over again.

"Midoriya, my boy", All Might said, sounding deeply concerned. "What on earth were you thinking?"

Izuku sobbed louder, struggling to balance the phone against his ear while he pressed down on Kacchan's bleeding wound.

"All Might", he lamented. "I'm so sorry, All Might".

"You should not have done that. There are plenty of pros here who could have acted", All Might reprehended, but there was comprehension in his tone. "… But", he added. "They *weren't* acting. So you had to take the matter into your own hands, hadn't you, Midoriya *shonen*?"

Izuku sniffed and gasped, still crying.

"I-It's Kacchan", he said, and that was enough of an explanation.

"Yes, *shonen*, I know", All Might sighed. Then, he paused. "What is the situation?"

"H-He w-was imp-paled", Izuku mustered, letting out another sob. "I'm – I'm applying pressure to t-the wound, b-b-but he's stuck, I can't get him out, and the m-metal is pinning him to t-the rubble. If – if I take it out, h-he'll – he'll –"

All Might breathed heavily, clearly distraught by that information.

"Is he conscious?", he asked, trying to sound calm. Izuku took a deep, shaky breath.

“K-Keeps waking up and p-passing out. I t-tried talking to him, but his – his h-hearing aid broke, I d-don’t think he can hear me”, he sniffed again. “I t-tried using sign language b-but he hit his h-head r-really b-bad. He – He – Oh, wait, wait up”, he cut himself off as Kacchan stirred back into awareness, blinking sluggishly.

He immediately tried to shrug away from Izuku’s hold and groaned in pain. Izuku awkwardly removed the phone from where it was barely balanced on his shoulder.

“H-Hold up, All Might, he’s waking up, just a m-minute”, he announced quickly before setting the phone down on the floor and pressing down on Kacchan’s side again. “Hey. Hey, Kacchan”, he called, before remembering Kacchan couldn’t hear him. Before he could lift one of his hands to sign at him, however, Kacchan’s eyes found his.

“Huh?”, he grunted, confused.

Izuku’s eyes widened.

“C-Can you hear me?!”, he exclaimed, relief overflowing him so hard it made him lightheaded.

Kacchan frowned.

“Huh…?”, he grunted again, confused.

Izuku sniffed, keeping his cool.

“Can you hear me? Kacchan?”, he asked again, raising his voice.

It took Kacchan a while to respond.

“Ki… Kinda”, he grimaced, throwing his head back in pain. “E-Ear’s ring’n”, he added with a grunt.

Then, after a few moments:

“’M st’ck”.

“I know”, Izuku nodded, relieved that at least Kacchan didn’t seem to have lost all of his hearing but going back to full-concern-mode upon the boy’s pained expression. “I’m working on that, ok?”

Kacchan squinted at him again.

“Wha’?”

“I’m working on that”, Izuku said louder, his hands never leaving Kacchan’s injury.

Kacchan grunted.

“Jus’ keep y’r st’pid ghost hands off me”, he muttered before passing out again.

A pause.

“Oh god”, Izuku said shakily before picking up his phone and awkwardly placing it between his ear and his shoulder again. “All Might?”

“All Might is talking to the pros”, a foreign voice said. “I’m a doctor. I need to know what we’re dealing with so we can move in with the proper equipment”.

Izuku swallowed dry.

“O-Ok. He’s stuck under the rubble. I don’t – I don’t know the extent of the damage to his lower half. I just removed the concrete crushing his head and his upper half, a-and then – then I noticed that – that there was – there’s this piece of metal sticking – o-out of him, right, uh, it’s right above his hipbone. Left side. The blood flow isn’t t-too intense, but it’s – it’s steady. I’m – I’m applying pressure, b-but he’s bleeding and he k-keeps passing out –“

“Ok, take deep breaths, hon. What’s your name again?”

“M-Midoriya. Izuku Midoriya”.

“All right, Midoriya-kun. And what is the name of the victim?”

“Kacchan”, he blurted out.

A pause.

“What was that?”, the woman asked.

Izuku bit his lip.

“I’m going to need a full name, hon. Can you give me that?”

Izuku let out a shaky breath, looking at Kacchan’s slack face before averting his eyes to the injury his hands were covering.

“B-Bakugou. He’s – His name is Katsuki Bakugou”.

“Ok. Can you tell me his age and blood type?”

“He’s 17, type A”, Izuku wavered. “Uh, his – his quirk is to sweat nitroglycerin –“

“You’re doing great, Midoriya-kun. Do you know if he has any pre-existent condition? Maybe some health issues, or any allergies?”

“H-He’s lost his hearing in one e-ear, and he’s allergic t-to shrimp and peanuts. Other than t-that, I – uh, I can’t think of anything –“

“Good, thank you. Now tell me, All Might mentioned something about a concussion. Is he coherent? Can you tell me if he has any other injuries you can see?”

“H-He hit the b-back of his head. Really bad. I ripped off some of m-my shirt to stanch it because the cut was bleeding a lot, b-but… It’s – It’s still –“

Izuku swallowed dry.

“H-He keeps waking up and passing out, and he repeats the same stuff, and – and he doesn’t seem to know w-where he is or – or what’s happening – and I can’t keep him awake –“

“Deep breaths, remember?”, the paramedic instructed.

Izuku nodded even though she couldn’t see it, trying to suck in a deep, nervous breath and ignore the way his arms were trembling.

“You’re doing amazing. Listen, Midoriya-kun”, she continued, firm. “We’re going to collect what we need to rescue Bakugou-kun without risking him bleeding out. But the rubble is highly unstable and experts say it is about to collapse completely very soon. It might take us a while to get to you without risking bringing everything down on you two, so please stay strong in there, ok? Keep applying pressure to the wound and try to keep Bakugou-kun awake if you can. We’ll be there as fast as we can”.

“All right”, Izuku breathed out.

“And there’s something else”, she added. “We need to know the extent of your injuries as well”.

Izuku hesitated, silent.

“Hiding it from me will cause more harm than good at this point”, she completed. “Your friends told me you were hurt before you stormed in. So please, don’t do anything that could get in the way of Bakugou-kun’s rescue. Tell me what your injuries are”.

Izuku swallowed dry, acknowledging the truth behind her words.

“I hit my head when the villains got me”, he admitted. “It needs stitches, but it’s nothing urgent”.

“Let us be the ones who decide that”, the paramedic offered. “Anything else?”

“Uh, I broke my nose”, Izuku said. “But that was before, too, with the villains. Other than that, I’m ok”.

“Hm”, the paramedic hummed. “Thank you, Midoriya-kun. We’re doing everything we can to get to you as soon as possible, ok? All you need to do for now is follow my instructions. I need to go, but one of your friends will talk to you now”.

“Okay”, Izuku said, but before he could even finish the word, another voice erupted on the phone.

“You know you’re in trouble, don’t you?”

Crap. That was Aizawa sensei.

“Yes, sensei”, Izuku said with shame in his voice, never ceasing to apply pressure to Kacchan’s wound.

“Good. I was worried you were thinking there wouldn’t be consequences for this”, Aizawa sensei huffed. “How is Bakugou?”

“He’s p-passed out right now”, Izuku swallowed dry, feeling strangely calmer – maybe talking to his teacher made him assume a more professional stance. “I’m applying pressure to the w-wound, but he’s losing a lot of blood”.

“Are you using just your hands?”

“My shirt”, Izuku explained. “I t-took it off and balled it up. But it’s – it’s not enough, sensei”.

A pause.

“I know. We’ll be there soon”.

“*Hai*”.

Another pause, pregnant.

“Midoriya”.

“Y-Yes?”

“If you pull something like this off again, you will be in real trouble. Are you aware?”

Izuku lowered his head, swallowing dry.

He knew there would be consequences. He *knew*, but this was Kacchan.

What was he supposed to do?

“I – I’m aware”.

“Good”.

Then, with a final shuffle, he was gone.

“*Deku-kun!*”, Uraraka’s shrieking voice came into the call. “What were you thinking! You shouldn’t have done that!”

“I know”, Izuku said, voice constrained.

“I know you know!”, Uraraka protested. Then, a yielding sigh. “Are you ok in there? How is Bakugou?”

A pause.

"He'll be ok", Izuku said, his eyes downcast. His words were meant to reassure himself more than her. "There's no other option".

Silence.

He hated that he felt guilty for saying that.

(He hated that he felt that he had lied.)

"Deku-kun…"

"Uraraka-san", Izuku interrupted her again before she could offer him comfort, holding back his tears of fear and sorrow. But he had nothing to say. So they stayed silent.

He could hear her breathing over the phone. He was pretty sure she could also hear his – heavy, labored, hitching pitifully in his throat as he tried his best not to cry again.

This was all too much, happening too fast. First, he didn't speak to Kacchan for six months, and then, after they finally spoke to each other again and opened a path to finally make peace…

And – And if Kacchan died before Izuku could settle things with him, if he lost Kacchan before they made things right – he'd… He'd…

It was too much. And he was having a hard time not panicking.

He needed to concentrate.

He adored Uraraka, but if he heard anyone telling him "everything will be all right" like she was bound to say, he would go in a spiral. He was sure of it. Because for things to eventually be all right, there had to be something wrong, first. And the "something wrong" was Kacchan literally dying on him.

"Everything will –"

"I – I'm going to hang up", he announced, cutting her off before she could finish. He needed to focus on keeping Kacchan awake, like the paramedic had required.

"Wait", she protested, worried.

"Please call when you guys have news. And – t-tell the pros to hurry. There's a fire in here".

"Deku-k–"

He grabbed his phone and ended the call before she could finish.

He sniffed quietly, poorly muffling his sobs as he continued to apply pressure to Kacchan's bleeding wound. This was a scenario he never thought would happen. This was something

out of his worst nightmares.

First, All Might retiring, now, Kacchan dying… How many more horrors would he be forced to witness before he even graduated? And after everything Kacchan went through, how much more would he need to suffer?

This wasn't fair. It wasn't fair that any of this was happening. And all the while Kacchan had been saving their friends, Izuku had been down there safely, paralyzed, unable to even walk on his own. Some great *hero* he was.

God, his guilt was overwhelming him. It was weighting so heavily on his shoulders he could barely even breathe.

"Ya lied t'me", Kacchan's croaked, breathy voice called his attention, lower than it had been the last time he woke up. As if he didn't have the energy to manage anything stronger.

Izuku's head immediately shot up at the sound, eyes wide.

"Kacchan? Can you hear me?", he asked, making sure to speak up so that the boy's impaired ears could understand him.

Kacchan's Adam's apple bobbed up and down as he swallowed dry a few times. His face was pale and covered in dust, but even beneath the beige Izuku could still see the sickening scorch marks on his skin and the worryingly bluish tone of his lips.

"Hey", Izuku said when he received no answer, leaning in even closer. "Are you with me?"

Kacchan just swallowed again, his face slack and tilted towards Izuku. God, the wheezing sound he was making was terrifying. He sounded like he could barely suck in any air, and he certainly looked like that too.

The sound was becoming more frequent, which was sending shivers of worry down Izuku's spine. He had been able to tell Kacchan wasn't breathing properly for a while now, but he had also figured *no one* would be able to breathe properly with a huge piece of metal impaling them. The bluish hue of Kacchan's lips told him a different story, though – it told him that not enough air was making it to Kacchan's lungs.

And he honestly had no idea what to do to fix that. He had already removed the boulder-like piece of concrete that had been crushing the upper half of Kacchan's body – there was nothing else pressing down on his chest. If this was related to his ribs – if, if they were broken or even… p-puncturing a lung…

Izuku wouldn't be able to do anything to help.

He would have to watch Kacchan suffocate until the pros and the doctors arrived.

Kacchan's good eye was blinking up at him and staring fixedly at him, albeit still glassy. He didn't respond.

Izuku bit his lower lip, nervous. *I need to keep him awake.*

“W-Why did I lie?”, Izuku asked, trying to urge him into a conversation. Izuku was desperate enough to try anything at this point.

Kacchan wheezed, a whistle-y, breathy sound, like he was attempting and failing to speak. And maybe it *wasn't* a good idea to make him speak, but Izuku frankly didn't know what else he could do to keep him awake because none of his attempts had worked so far. On the other hand, Kacchan could barely breathe, let alone talk. Oh god, what was he doing?

“Hey, you know what? Why don't you tell me later and right now you focus on –“, he attempted, but Kacchan managed a *scoff*, of all things to do on that moment, before groaning.

“Y… Ya said…”, he swallowed, gasped. “Y' didn' know h'w”.

Izuku frowned.

“Didn't know how?”, he asked, confused.

“Wha'?”, Kacchan asked, not having heard him.

“What didn't I know?”, Izuku asked, louder.

Kacchan wheezed.

“M'name”.

Izuku stared at him.

“W… What?”, he frowned again.

Kacchan sighed with difficulty as his head lolled closer towards Izuku.

“Y' call me K'cchan c'se you don' know how t'say m'name prop'rly”, he mustered out, exhausted. “B't y' jus' did”.

Izuku opened and closed his mouth.

So Kacchan had heard his phone call? He had been awake the whole time?

“Oh”, Izuku blinked. “Well… I needed to tell her your whole name, Kacchan. She was a doctor”.

“St'p”, Kacchan grunted, closing his good eye with a grimace.

“I can't stop applying pressure. I know it hurts, I'm sorry, but I –“

“No”, Kacchan protested, eyes still closed. “No' th't”.

Izuku was silent for a moment, dread pooling on his stomach.

“You… You want me to call you… *Katsuki*?”, he tested the name in his tongue.

Kacchan's grimace intensified, as if the name had displeased him profoundly.

It felt unnatural to Izuku, too. It was one thing to tell a paramedic who was going to help save Kacchan's life his whole name during a moment of crisis… But it was an entirely different thing to voluntarily call Kacchan… *that*. He hadn't even called Kacchan that during the League's attack back at the Training Camp. He couldn't even call Kacchan that in his *head*.

"Don' like tha', D'ku", Kacchan protested, sounding annoyed.

"Yeah", Izuku chuckled wetly, but the sound was more melancholic than anything. "I don't like that, either".

"B't y're still a li'r", Kacchan wheezed softly, reopening his one good eye and staring at the sky above them through the hole. It was almost navy blue, at this point.

A pregnant pause.

"I never lied to you in my life", Izuku said, sincerity and sobriety suddenly overwhelming his tone. "If anything, you're the only person who I never lie to".

Kacchan's good eye averted from the sky to focus on his face.

"I really didn't know how to say it, before", Izuku shrugged, his hands still pressing down on Kacchan's wound. "But I was kind of forced to learn it. When I did speech therapy".

Kacchan blinked at him.

"B-But… Well. It feels wrong, to call you anything other than 'Kacchan' at this point", he admitted, looking away with a sad expression.

A few moments passed.

"Feels wr'ng t'call y' Izuk', too", Kacchan admitted, voice raspy and constrained.

Izuku looked at him with tears in his eyes.

Kacchan stared back at him, looking tired and in pain. His one good eye was half-lidded.

"C-Can…", he swallowed dry. "Can you say that again?"

Kacchan squinted.

"Y' r'ly wan' me to?", he slurred, wheezing.

Izuku just lowered his head, neither confirming nor denying. He felt selfish, and guilty, and terribly, terribly sad. He wished the damn pros would just *arrive* already.

Getting to Kacchan but not being able to save his life was meaningless. It rendered him powerless. It was equivalent to arriving in time to watch his death. Izuku wished there was something – anything – he could possibly do without risking killing Kacchan in the process.

“Iz… Izuku”, Kacchan wheezed out.

Izuku looked at him, eyes full of tears. Kacchan continued to stare back at him, waiting for a reaction.

A prolonged, meaningful silence. Izuku broke it by sniffing.

“It really does sound weird”, Izuku ended up chuckling, even though his face was the portrait of sadness and his cheeks were matted with new tears. Kacchan gave him a lopsided grin and closed his eye again.

Izuku gazed at him lovingly.

“Please, don’t fall asleep”, he begged, his voice tender. “You need to stay awake”.

“I kn’w”, Kacchan wheezed, eyes still closed. “’M just rest’n”.

“Don’t rest”, Izuku immediately reprimanded. “Not just yet. Please?”

Kacchan opened his eye again, glaring at him. It felt weak and dim compared to his usual blazing glare, but at least it was something – it was a sign he was still there, and he was still fighting. Izuku smiled at him again.

Kacchan sighed, seeming annoyed. A slight frown appeared on his forehead.

“Why’re we h’re?”, he asked, confused. Izuku bit his lower lip.

“We’re waiting for the pros”, he provided. “They’re coming to get us out”.

“Why?”, Kacchan’s frown intensified.

“The building’s highly unstable”, Izuku explained. “They need to help me move you without disrupting any of the rubble”.

Kacchan stared at him as if he was speaking another language.

“Why y’ need h’lp movin’ me?”, he questioned, sounding almost scornful. Izuku blinked at him.

“Y-You’re…”, he hesitated. “You’re really hurt, Kacchan”.

Kacchan gave him a breathless scoff.

“S’ wha’?”, he asked. “J’st a c’ple of br’ken ribs an’ a c’ncussion. I’ll be f’ne”.

Izuku felt the blood drain from his face. Carefully, he pressed down harder on Kacchan’s bleeding injury, feeling as the warm, sticky blood pooled around his fingers from the already drenched shirt.

No reaction. No whimper, no grimace, not even a twitch of his eyebrows.

“Did you… feel that?”, Izuku asked carefully, his voice small. Kacchan frowned at him.

“Feel wha’?”, he slurred.

Izuku swallowed dry, breath hitching in his throat.

“N-Nothing”, he said. “I-It’s… It’s… N-Nothing, Kacchan”, he said, heart breaking.

So much for never lying to him in his life, huh.

Kacchan narrowed his eyes at him, suspicious, but the expression was soon washed away by dazedness. His face went slack and he stared at nothing for a while before turning his glassy eyes back at Izuku.

“D-Deku…?”, he called, sounding – hesitant? Like he had passed out and woken up again in a matter of seconds.

“Yes, Kacchan?”, Izuku responded, doing his best to keep a calming face and tone of voice.

It took Kacchan a while to respond, his eyes vacant and far away.

“Wh’r’s y’r shirt?”, he asked eventually, the hint of curiosity in his small voice.

Izuku swallowed dry.

“I had to take it out”, he responded simply, hoping the evasive answer would suffice for the time being.

It earned him a frown instead.

“’rent ya… cold?”, Kacchan questioned.

Izuku sniffed and wiped his fresh rolling tears away with his shoulder.

“No, I’m just fine”, he said, offering Kacchan a forced smile. “Why? Are *you* cold?”

Kacchan looked like he was about to respond, but then his head lolled heavily slightly to the side, limp, as if he couldn’t sustain its weight anymore. His lips parted and his eyes were still open, albeit sightless. His face went slack again.

“Hey”, Izuku called desperately, heart racing. “Hey, don’t fall asleep. Ok? We have an agreement. No falling asleep until Deku is out of the wrecked building, remember? Do you remember it? Kacchan?”

Kacchan’s good eye stared vacantly at nothing for a few moments before it rolled and fluttered shut once more.

His head was pounding.

“I *know* that”, Deku was whining in a high-pitched voice and *god, can’t he just shut his trap up?* “But you don’t understand, we don’t *have* that time! Just – I don’t know – Just *do* something – I can’t move him”, he pleaded, desperate.

Katsuki wanted to tell him to keep it down, but the pain in his head was too grand. Weirdly enough, he wasn’t feeling anything else.

Just the rhythmic throbs at the back of his skull and the cold. He was really, really cold.

What the hell was happening?

“Can’t – look, wait, I have an idea. Is Uraraka-san there? Can I speak to her?”

Katsuki managed to open his eye. The sky up above was dark blue, a few spread-out stars shining in the distance.

“Yes, let me – oh, wait. Hold up. Kacchan?”, he called, voice louder.

Katsuki blinked again, eyes focused on the stars.

“Hey, Kacchan”, Deku tried again, a hand cupping Katsuki’s cheek and turning his head towards him. Away from the stars. His face was blurry, but Katsuki could still see the way he was frowning.

Huh. There was blood on his face. And on his neck. And on his arms, and on his hand.

“Y’re hurt?”, Katsuki frowned. If Deku was hurt, then he needed to get the hell out of there and get himself some help. What the hell was the idiot thinking? Why didn’t he look after himself?

“I’m ok, Kacchan”, Deku said, sounding like he was about to cry. In fact, if Katsuki had squinted his one open eye, he would have been able to see the way Deku’s face was covered in tears – some still fresh.

“Why’re y’cryin’?”, he asked, even though it felt rhetorical – Deku was *always* crying.

It had always been like that. Katsuki was the amazing, brave, strong, one, and Deku was the helpless crybaby trailing after him.

Right…?

Katsuki could still remember how Deku would always cry when he got nervous, or scared, or uncomfortable back when they were kids. There had been this one time, maybe on Katsuki's 6th or 7th birthday…? He had demanded to have as many candles on his cake as possible, those electronic types that burst loudly and brightly and whose songs kept going on forever until someone smashed the thing with a hammer. And his mom, being his mom, had bought him 6 or 7 of those – the number that matched his birthday. The cake had been so covered in that shit that the All Might topping was barely even seeable beneath all that bright fire when his dad lit them up.

And while Katsuki had stood triumphantly on a chair in front of the cake, cherishing and thriving on all the attention he was receiving, and even letting of some tiny explosions with his precocious hands to match the lit candles of his cake, he had spotted Deku's tear-blotched face in the crowd.

He had been sobbing brokenly and hugging himself, wide, wet eyes sparkling and reflecting the fire of the candles. No one had paid him any mind, since he was *always fucking crying*, but at least he had tried to be discreet about it instead of making a scene. And once everyone had resumed the happy birthday song and his mom had started to cut the pieces of cake, Katsuki had hopped off the chair – without any help, thank you very much – and found Deku, grabbing his wrist and pulling him towards the still-fuming cake.

Deku had protested, trying to free himself from Katsuki's grasp and to run away, but Katsuki was stronger – he had always been stronger. He had dragged the struggling boy across the room and pushed him towards the cake, the blown-out candles still emitting an annoying little distorted song, but no longer on fire. Katsuki had pointed at the smoke before looking at Deku, his hand never letting go of the small wrist.

"*See, Deku?*", he had said. "*You shouldn't be scared of the fire. It's just fire*".

Deku had sobbed, lower lip wobbling.

"*B-But it's so loud and noisy and scary!*", he had protested, clinging to Katsuki's shirt.

"*It won't hurt you, silly. It's just a candle, look*", he had reached out and picked one up, the topping of the cake sticking to his hand as he showed it to Deku. The plastic was hot, but holdable. "*You're being stupid. Would All Might be scared of a candle?*"

Deku had put on a concentrated face and shaken his head then, serious. He had reached out and grabbed the candle from Katsuki, his hand getting dirty with the topping in the process as well.

"*O-Ok*", Deku had agreed, holding the candle and looking at it with a serious face.

The expression deflated into sadness just a moment later, as if he had thought better about the subject.

"*But I don't like fire. I think it's scary*", he protested.

"*Is that why you didn't want to be Endeavor when we were playing hero in the park?*", Katsuki had given him a childish scoff, mocking.

Deku had pouted at him.

"*I wanted to be All Might*", he had protested.

"*Only brave heroes like me get to be All Might!*", Katsuki had boasted triumphantly, drawing the attention of the other kids nearby. "*Silly heroes who cry at candles have to be someone else*".

"*Hey! That's not fair!*", Deku had protested, getting pushed away by the other kids gathering around Katsuki. "*There was too much fire*", he tried to defend himself, but his voice came out too low – no one was paying any attention anymore.

"*Fire isn't scary! Fire is cool!*", Katsuki had exclaimed, throwing his hands up in the air and letting off a few tiny explosions. "*Look, Deku! Watch my quirk!*"

"*Katsuki!!*", Mitsuki had protested then, voice booming in anger. "*I already told you not to do that inside!*"

"*W-Wow*", Deku had gaped in admiration, as he always did whenever Katsuki showed off.

"*I'm gonna be King Explosion and if you wanna be my sidekick then you can't be scared of fire*", he had stated, running across the living room and away from his mom in an attempt to pretend he hadn't heard her.

"*Hey, I wanna be your sidekick!*", one of the kids that had trailed after him exclaimed.

"*Yeah, me too!*", another had agreed.

"*Katsuki Bakugou, stop doing that right now or there won't be any fucking cake for any of those brats!!*", Mitsuki had shouted.

"*Mitsuki! Don't swear in front of the kids!*", Masaru had reproached.

"*If I need to babysit this bunch of brats then I get to say whatever the hell I want! They won't even remember it!*"

"*Deku, when are you getting your fucking quirk?*", Katsuki had immediately asked, still popping off some explosions.

"*Oh god!!*", Masaru had paled, rushing towards his son, while Mitsuki laughed loudly in the distance. "*Katsuki, no swearing –*"

"*Why don't you have a quirk yet? That's taking too loooong*", Katsuki had teased again while his father picked him up into his arms. Deku's head had hung low.

"*I don't know*", he had shrugged, embarrassed and avoiding everyone else's eyes. "*Mom says it should come up any time now*".

"*Well, you should hurry*", Katsuki had said maliciously, with the sort of mockery only children could achieve. "*Because if I'm gonna have a sidekick, he can't be quirkless. And there are a lot of people who want to be my sidekick because I'm so cool, and I don't want to keep waiting so much*".

"*Now, now, Katsuki*", Masaru had told him, still holding him in his arms. "*Give little Izuku-kun his time. I'm sure his quirk will manifest soon and then you'll be able to play together, all right? But you know mommy's rule, no explosions inside the house. And daddy's rule says no swearing, either!*"

"*Fuck!"*, Katsuki had exclaimed in defiance, making all of his little friends except for Deku burst into immediate laughter. Masaru had looked more horrified than angry.

"*Katsuki…*", he had tried, half-hearted.

"*Fuck, fuck, fuck! Hell! Shit! Boom, boom, boom!*", Katsuki had exclaimed in a childish voice, throwing his hands up again and setting off more tiny explosions.

That had earned him more laughter and even some cheering from his friends, which encouraged him to keep going. Instead of scolding him, Masaru had simply put him back down on the floor with a frustrated sigh, shaking his head in disapproval.

"We're going to have a serious talk after this party is over, young man", Masaru had told him meekly, but his half-hearted words went unheard by Katsuki and the group of children following him as he ran around the living room. He was setting off even more explosions while the other kids cheered and chased after him, and Masaru soon gave up trying to catch his son's attention.

"It's the little brat's birthday", Mitsuki had said once her husband approached her, gazing at her happy son with affection. "Let him live a little".

And Deku had tried to keep up with Katsuki, even if his face had still been wet with tears. When Mitsuki finally finished cutting the cake, Katsuki had dragged Deku closer to the table again. He had hesitated when Mitsuki offered him the cake, so Katsuki had grabbed the plate from his mom's hand and turned towards the shy Deku, an impatient look on his face.

"*Are you still scared?*", he had asked, annoyed. Deku had hesitated before putting on a forced brave look.

"*N-No*", he had shaken his head.

Katsuki had handed him the cake, which Deku took after just a split second of hesitation.

"*It's just cake, silly Deku. And before it was just fire. Stop being such a crybaby*", he had reproached, and before Deku had the chance to respond, he had run off to his other friends with more explosions to offer.

"Y'd'n h've t'be sc'red", Katsuki mumbled out, voice rough and slurred. His eye was rolling sightlessly in its socket, lids fluttering close and open nonstop. "'s j'st fire, D'ku".

“ – to float the concrete beneath him so we don’t have to take the metal out – oh, wait, he’s woken up again”, Deku was telling someone, and wait, what was that?

What was he talking about? Had Katsuki fallen asleep?

“ –cchan? Kacchan, are you with me?”, Deku was asking him, shaking his shoulder. Katsuki opened his eye and – wait, when had he closed it?

“Huh?”, he groaned, confused. The sky above him was black.

“Hey”, Deku smiled at him, overly gentle. “It’s ok. Help is almost here, so just try and stay conscious, ok? Just a bit longer?”

Katsuki frowned at him. Deku’s face was matted with dried blood, but the pale skin was tinged orange. Katsuki realized it was because of the fire burning bright somewhere beside them, which – was kind of weird. Why were they sitting right next to a fire?

“W’re ar’we?”, Katsuki slurred, voice weak. “Wha’…?”

“It’s ok”, Deku told him again, a fat tear rolling down his cheek. “We’re almost out of here”.

Where *was* here? Where were they? Why was there fire? Why was Deku bleeding? Why was Deku crying?

Was it because of the fire?

“’s just f’re”, Katsuki repeated. “Y’ don’ hav’ to b’scar’d”.

Deku downright sobbed at this, face scrunching up in pain and sadness.

Had Katsuki caused that reaction? What was going on?

“D’ku”, Katsuki called, confused and worried. He needed – he *wanted* – to understand what was happening. But Deku didn’t look at him.

“Kacchan”, he sniffed, voice tight and head downcast. “Please, just – just stay strong for me, ok? Just stay awake?”

Katsuki wanted to protest and tell him he had no reason to just fall asleep out of nowhere like an elderly man, but he found himself too breathless to do that. He tried to pull at the collar of his shirt in order to clear his airway, but found that he couldn’t.

“D’ku?”, he called again, annoyed and confused. What the hell had the nerd done *now*? “Wh’re ar’ m’ hands?”

Deku continued to cry, but he shook his head and tried to keep a steady voice when he answered.

“I told you, Kacchan, your hands are fine. You don’t have to worry about them so much, ok?”, he said, seeming desperate. Katsuki frowned.

“’kay”, he complied, but just because Deku seemed really distraught. Maybe they were in some deep shit or something. He sighed and closed his eyes for a second, just to organize his thoughts and figure out what they should do...

“*NO SLEEPING*!”, Deku downright shrieked, making Katsuki jolt in surprise and reopen his eye in a heartbeat. What the fuck??? “Sorry, Kacchan, just – I never know if you’re going to wake up again when you close your eyes, so please, please, *please*, stay awake, ok? Just a little longer?”

Katsuki frowned.

“Wasn’ gonn’ sleep”, he protested, hating how weird his voice sounded. He tried to clear his throat, but found he didn’t have the energy. So all he did was lie there and keep wheezing.

“Yeah, sure”, Deku chuckled drily, humorlessly. Katsuki looked at him.

Something weird was going on, but he couldn’t really tell what. He felt like he should remember – something urgent and unknown nagging at the back of his brain. But the more he tried, the more tired he felt. The fact that he could barely suck in any breath was certainly not helping his efforts.

Also, he felt like he should be way more worried about the amount of blood covering Deku, but his frantic heart was already beating too fast, barely leaving any room for anything inside it.

“Why’re y’ bleed’n?”, he managed to choke out, even if his burning lungs protested.

Deku looked at him, face serious and worried. He sniffed again.

There was a moment of hesitation, during which Deku seemed to argue with himself whether or not he should be frank with Katsuki – whether or not Katsuki would comprehend his answer. Then, after biting his lower lip and taking a deep breath, he settled for saying:

“It’s not my blood. So don’t worry, ok?”

Katsuki frowned for a moment, trying to understand.

Not his blood? Then whose blood was it?

He noticed Deku seemed to be pressing down on something. Was he hiding an injury from Katsuki? If he was, he would be really pissed. Deku really sucked at self-preservation, but hiding a whole ass injury was a new level of jackassery.

He craned his head to look. And then he saw the huge piece of metal protruding from his own abdomen.

Oh.

Oh.

Oh shit.

Oh *fuck*.

So that was why he was feeling so fucking weird. And why everything was confusing and swimming around him. And why he couldn't breathe. And why he felt so cold. And why Deku was covered in blood. And why Deku was crying so much. And why he couldn't hold on to a thought for more than a few seconds, why he felt dizzy and lightheaded and – and – and –

Things were starting to come back to him with such stark clarity that he felt even dizzier, and how the fuck – why was Deku here, how did he get here, hadn't the fucking place blown up to pieces – how – why – was he even fucking safe –

"Don't look, Kacchan", Deku instructed, nervous, trying to push him back into lying down, but Katsuki's eye was fixed on the horrid wound. "Please, don't look".

"I don' feel it", he found himself blurting out before he could even catch up with the fact that, yes, he *couldn't feel it.* And why the hell couldn't he feel the literal *hole* in his stomach?

His voice was small and blood started to drain from his face as he realized what was happening to him.

He was fucking dying.

His cheeks felt really cold, out of a sudden – as did his entire body. He was *freezing.*

"Do'sn't hurt", he continued, frowning, nervous. A wound as gruesome like that should be hurting, right? Shouldn't he be in tremendous pain? Shouldn't he be feeling something other than just numbness and cold? His eye found Deku, searching his face for answers.

"Yes, I know, but you don't have to worry, ok?", Deku smiled forcedly again, the same smile from when he pretended not to be scared of the candles on the cake. "I'm handling it. I'm not letting you bleed out, I'm going to take care of it until help arrives. They're almost here, so you don't have to worry, all right? *Please*, don't worry".

Katsuki squinted at him.

"Y'said y'nev'r lie to me", he protested. Because he could see right through Deku's bullshit – he could *always* see right through it.

And right now, he could see how scared Deku was. How sad he seemed to be. And he wasn't an idiot – he knew that a wound like that wasn't child's play, and that, from the amount of *his* blood covering Deku, he probably didn't have much longer. The fact that Deku hadn't dragged him out of there told him what he needed to know – that there was no safe way to remove the piece of metal impaling him, and that he'd probably kick the bucket as soon as anyone tried.

Which meant Deku was lying to make him feel better. Deku was *sugar-coating* him. And there was nothing Katsuki fucking hated more than *that.*

Deku seemed to realize this, because something somber flashed across his face – something akin to guilt, and decision, and determination, all at the same time. He bit his lower lip and looked away before meeting Katsuki's eyes again.

"You – You're right", he nodded, swallowing dry. "I never lie to you, Kacchan. And you're really hurt, but I'm not *lying* when I say you don't have to worry. We're going to fix this, ok? All you have to do is lie there, stay awake, and believe in me. I'm not letting you die like this. Do you trust me?"

Katsuki stared at him, sluggish brain trying to apply some meaning to the sounds Deku was making with his mouth. He could mostly hear it, even if the words sounded low and muffled and distant beneath all the ringing in his ear. Once he comprehended the message, he nodded – before he could really think about it. Before he could even feel angry at himself for agreeing with Deku so easily right after he was lied to.

Because he *did* trust Deku. And he knew that the idiot would rather eat his own hand than to let Katsuki die on him.

That knowledge – that realization – felt so natural and easy to him on that moment of weakness and blood-loss that Katsuki felt once again like an idiot for ever doubting Deku's devotion to him. The most primordial bit of his consciousness – the oldest part of himself – insisted that he should be offended by Deku making him those promises and telling him those things. *Of course* he wouldn't fucking die. He didn't need Deku to vow that, or to take that responsibility into his hands. He didn't need to owe Deku his life because of this. He wasn't *weak*, he could handle it.

But at the same time, the new part of himself – that part that took over his subconscious and that made him nod his agreement at Deku so promptly, so easily – *knew* that Deku applying pressure to his wound was keeping him alive. And this new part knew better than to begrudge him for that, or to feel inferior, or to feel looked-down on – on that moment, he didn't have the chance to feel anything other than relief.

He was fucking dying. That put some things into a new perspective.

A *lot* of things.

Deku sighed in relief, unaware of Katsuki's epiphany, nodding as well and lowering his head. He picked the phone up again and placed it on his shoulder.

"Hi. Do you have an ETA?", he asked, voice wavering.

Katsuki watched him. He looked very concentrated. Deku's brow was scrunched up and his face looked pale, but determined. His shoulders were tense as he continued to press down on the wound on Katsuki's stomach, phone poorly balanced between his ear and one shoulder.

His hands and arms were completely covered in crimson, but Katsuki's blood had found a way to sprinkle itself all the way up to Deku's face. The rest of the blood there – the dried one, mixed with dust – was his own. Coming from his forehead.

Katsuki frowned. He vaguely remembered the source of that injury, but he couldn't quite put his finger on it… there was something about villains, and a deposit, and maybe duct tape…

Villains. Fuck, the *villains*.

You're the explosion boy! I wonder who they'll blame for the whole building blowing up to pieces, huh? I wonder what your precious hero society will do for you now, after you've caused so much damage and death.

Katsuki gasped, desperately trying to look around. Was there anyone else injured? Buried beneath the rubble like he was? Bleeding out and dying with each breath they took?

Did they think *he* had caused this?

"Hey, Kacchan", Deku called him, phone still pressed against his ear. "Try to stay still –"

"'s there an'one else?", Katsuki slurred, agitated and frowning. His voice sounded so small and weak, but he could no longer bring himself to care about that.

"What?"

"An'one else", Katsuki swallowed. "Is – I-Is th're – A-Are peopl'…", he coughed, wincing.

"Kacchan", Deku told him gently, rubbing his face on Katsuki's shoulder, and why the fuck did he do that for? "No one else is hurt. You saved everyone".

Katsuki stared at him, trying to swallow and breathe and stay awake.

"Wasn' me", he mustered out, dizzy. "Wasn' me, D'ku".

Deku looked like he was doing his best not to sob again.

"I know", he told him, voice trembling. "I know this wasn't you, Kacchan. I'll let them know, ok? I'll tell everyone it was the villains", he nodded, eyes pooling with new tears. "But do you remember what happened?"

Katsuki searched his addled memory for a while, trying to put the scattered pieces of information floating in the darkness of his brain in order. He *had* remembered what happened, but he had also already forgotten, his poorly-oxygenated brain struggling to hold onto memories for more than a few moments.

"Th'r' w're m're bombs", he forced out. "Guy spat acid on'em".

Deku nodded.

"And you realized what was happening and threw everyone out, right?", he asked, sorrowful.

Katsuki swallowed and screwed his good eye shut, nodding.

"H' said peopl'd think 'twas me", he choked out. "B'cause… th' expl'sion…"

“Shh, shh, I know”, Deku rubbed his face on Katsuki’s shoulder again. “You don’t have to worry. You saved the people in there, they’ll tell the police you had nothing to do with that. Ok?”

Katsuki swallowed again, grimacing, even though he could no longer feel any pain.

“Wasn’ me”, he repeated in spite of himself. The thought of people thinking that he had purposefully caused all that destruction, that he was as bad as those villains – the thought that *Deku* might have thought that of him… It sent shivers down his spine.

And why did he care so much what a bunch of extras would think of him? Why was this his primary concern while he was literally on the verge of dying?

Why, *why*? Why had he become this person who cared so much about this kind of shit? Why was this new part of himself such a wimp, such a loser, such a pathetic little softie? He shouldn’t give a *shit* what people would think! He shouldn’t give a shit if they thought he had caused this! He shouldn’t give a shit whether or not he was living up to Deku’s shitty standards! He shouldn’t… He… He shouldn’t…

“I didn’… I…”, his head lolled to the side, exhausted. His heart was beating fast inside his chest, out of rhythm. It kept skipping some beats, and the distress he was feeling only made everything worse.

“Hey”, Deku called his attention, and only then Katsuki realized his eye had been slipping shut. He reopened it quickly, now scared of losing consciousness. What if he went to sleep and never woke up again? He couldn’t fight Death if he was unconscious. “Keep talking to me. Ok?”, Deku told him, sounding equally scared.

Katsuki looked at him, silent.

He needed to stay awake.

His heart continued to feel weird inside his chest. It felt as if it was struggling to keep pumping his blood across his body. Which was comprehensible, since most of the blood seemed to be *leaving* his body, rather than staying inside, if Deku’s appearance was anything to go by.

But maybe if it stopped racing inside his chest so much, the blood would leak out of him more slowly. It would buy him more time. However, the more Katsuki tried to control his heart rate, the more it seemed to race. The fact that he could barely breathe in any air was certainly not helping.

His lips felt numb. Actually, his whole body felt numb. He didn’t even feel that cold anymore.

Thinking about it, he didn’t really feel much of anything.

Not even the determination to keep fighting for his life – just the panic that he might lose that battle. But Deku said he’d be ok, didn’t he? He might have spent most of his life hating

Deku, but he had always trusted him. He knew him.

He *trusted* him. That was a fact about his new self – he trusted him.

He didn't want to be a person who would allow themselves to die just because they were too proud to take Deku's help. He didn't want to be a person who would allow themselves to die just out of spite, out of a grudge, out of *ego.* He was bleeding out and numb all over. He was struggling more and more to stay awake and keep up a fight. He could barely even breathe. He was *dying*.

And he was terrified out of his mind.

If he died, he would never become number one. Never become a hero. Never beat Deku at the charts, never beat All Might, never conquer his life-long dream.

He was only 17. He had a whole life ahead of him. A whole career, a whole legacy. And he was dying. He was *dying*. Before he even graduated, before he even opened his own agency, before he even made a name for himself, before he even became number one. His whole life, everything he had planned and spent so much time working his ass for, everything was about to end – and he was – he was only 17, there was so much he still had to learn and conquer and perfect and it was – it was about to end and he *didn't want it to end,* he didn't want to go, not like this, not now, *please not now,* he didn't want to die, he didn't want to go –

His heart started to race further, desperate and skipping even more beats. His eyelid began to droop again, too heavy for him to keep open because of his arrhythmia. He could almost feel his consciousness slipping away, which made him desperate because *I gotta keep fighting, if I pass out, I won't wake up, I have to stay awake, I can't fall asleep, I can't let go, I don't want to go, I need to stay awake –*

Kacchan, there was a voice calling him, but it was distant and muffled and so, so far away. Katsuki tried to open his eye again – *fuck, it closed, it closed, don't let it close again –*, because he *really* didn't want to fall asleep, but everything was swimming around him. He couldn't even tell up from down anymore.

It was scary. At least when he was cold, he could feel something. When he was in pain, there was sensory stimulation. Like this… there was nothing. Nothing. Nothing to keep him attached to reality, nothing to make him tell the difference from when he was awake and when he was drifting off. Nothing to keep him grounded – not even Deku's hand anymore.

Everything was mixing together – sounds, colors, smells, feelings. His senses became overloaded with a pandemonium of stimuli, his panicked mind a tone-deaf symphony of chaos.

His head was suddenly jostled to the side, and it took Katsuki's slow brain a few moments to realize Deku had slapped his face. Weirdly enough, he didn't feel it. His cheeks were fully numb, senseless.

"Thin' 'm gonna p'ss out", he found it in himself to muster out, because he figured it would be better to let Deku know; maybe he could do something about it. But his voice was barely

audible, and the ringing in his ear was starting to grow too intense – he couldn't even be sure if he had actually said the words aloud or if he had just thought about saying them. They continued to echo in his brain as he tried to remember if he had just imagined them, *think I'm gonna pass out think I'm gonna pass out think I'm gonna pass out think I'm gonna pass out think I'm gonna pass out*

"*No*", a strong, angry voice shouted at him, but it was so far away… *think I'm gonna pass out…*

His head was jostled again. Another slap, which he didn't feel. Wow, all that senselessness was really freaking him out… Hah…

"Aren't you the one who will surpass All Might?", the voice shouted at him, angry. His reflex was to shout back at it, but he couldn't even feel his tongue anymore. "Won't you become the number one hero?"

He will. *I want to*. He didn't want to die like this…

Katsuki managed to open his glassy eye again, but it once more kept rolling in its socket, unable to focus or to see anything properly.

"*Keep fighting*", Deku shouted at him, seeming furious, now. "Don't give up. Don't you *dare* give up, Kacchan. You are the hero who smiles at the face of danger".

Katsuki tried to find him, to look at him. He tried to say something in response, but his tongue was cotton. There was something clogged at the back of his throat, keeping him from breathing. His airway was completely blocked now, he realized finally.

Before, he had been managing to suck in a few limited, scarce breaths. Now, he was downright suffocating. No air was making it through. *No air was making it through.*

Was that why he felt so dizzy? Why it was harder to stay awake and to form words?

I won't give up, he wanted to say. *I can't give up*.

I can't die like this.

"I always admired you, not because you never lose", Deku continued, sobbing. "But because you *never* give up. Just like All Might. Even when all odds are against you, you *keep. going.* So you'd better not start throwing in the towel now, you hear me? Because I still want to be the hero who surpasses you, and you're not going to let me win so easily, will you? *Will* you?! Will you let *me* surpass you?"

Katsuki wanted to shake his head, because *hell fucking no he wouldn't, and he wouldn't fucking give up either,* but he was frozen. Maybe the cold had finally caught up to him and frozen his limbs to the floor. He tried to speak again, but nothing came out, just a breathless wheeze. His lungs burned.

"Kacchan?", Deku called, sounding horrified, as if he had just realized something terrible. "Are you – Can you breathe?"

Katsuki just lied there, lungs burning and screaming. He tried to suck in another breath, a horrible noise coming from his throat, but he failed. Black and white spots were swimming in front of his one open eye.

“You gotta breathe”, Deku told him nervously, voice trembling as he dragged himself closer to Katsuki’s head on the floor. “C’mon, just breathe. P-Please?”

Katsuki was trying. Couldn’t the asshole see that? What the fuck did he mean *please,* as if Katsuki was holding his fucking breath on fucking purpose?! He couldn’t breathe, he just *couldn’t*, no matter how he tried, and there was black appearing at the corners of his eye.

He didn’t want to die like this. He was so numb.

“Hey, I’m here”, Deku told him, pressing down harder on his injury with both hands. “I’m here with you. Help is almost here. Just hang on a little longer, ok? Please? Deep breaths, take it slow, ok?”

I’m trying, Katsuki wanted to say. *Can’t you see I’m fucking trying? I’m trying so hard. I don’t want to die. I don’t want to die, not now, not like this.*

His heart rate was anything but steady. His heart continued to skip beats. It was frantic, and unrhythmical, and verging on tachycardic. He tried to suck in another breath, but all he managed was a short gasp. His skull felt like it was about to explode from the pressure inside it.

Tears pooled in his one open eye. He could hear the soft puffs coming out through his gaping mouth.

“D… k…”, he choked – gurgled – out, weak and breathless. He sounded like he was drowning in mud.

“I’m here, Kacchan, please, don’t give up”, Deku hyperventilated, crying desperately. He was clearly freaking out. “Where the *hell* are you?”, he screamed, his tone way snappier than Katsuki remembered it.

You kiss your mother with that mouth?, Katsuki wanted to say, right before thinking: *Huh. I’m right here. Can’t the nerd see me?*

“I know, but I’m losing him!”, Katsuki heard him scream. Oh, right, he had been on the phone with someone. He totally forgot about that. “Just *hurry*!”

A noise came from somewhere behind them. From the way Deku jolted, flinched, and yelped in surprise, the noise was probably *way* louder than Katsuki’s impaired hearing perceived it.

“Yes, that was right behind us!”, Deku yelled. “We’re a bit more to the front, you’ll see an opening on the ground! There’s a pocket right beneath you, we’re inside!”

A pocket? How could they be inside a damn pocket? Had the villain’s quirk shrunk them or something? Was that why Katsuki was feeling so weird and detached from his own body? But if they were in a villain’s pocket, he needed to get himself and Izuku out…

“P-Please, hurry, I don’t think he’s breathing!”, Deku begged, frantically. “I know, just use your quirk to lift it up!”

Katsuki’s good eye widened.

The quirk.

He still had Izuku’s quirk.

He…

He needed to give it back.

“D… k…”, he gurgled out, breathless and wheezing. The black on the corners of his eye was starting to spread in, and he was sure he was about to lose consciousness any second now, no matter how hard he fought against it.

“I’m right here, Kacchan”, Deku gave him that annoying forced smile again. “They’re almost here, ok? They’re arriving”, he reassured him. “Just a few more seconds. I promise”.

Katsuki gazed at him. Izuku looked so sad. So scared.

He wanted to reach out and cup Izuku’s face on his hand. He wanted to apologize for taking his quirk and for being a piece of shit. He wanted to tell him it would be ok and that he wouldn’t die. He didn’t know *why* he wanted to do those things, but there wasn’t enough oxygen in his brain for him to really focus on the rational part of his thought process. All he knew was what he was feeling.

For the first time in a long, long while, he knew what he was feeling.

And he might be numb all over. He might not be able to feel his face anymore, he might be incapable of even moving, but there was warmness in his chest as he gazed into Izuku’s green, big, expressive eyes.

“K-Kacchan…?”, Deku asked, unsettled by unusually soft the look in Katsuki’s battered face.

Katsuki continued to gaze at him, lost in the green of his irises. It felt so familiar, and reassuring, in a way.

It felt like home. He knew those eyes since he knew himself. No matter where they stood in their relationship with each other, Izuku had always been there. His eyes gave Katsuki the comfort and the certainty that he would always have someone to trust, someone to rival him. Someone to be there for him, and someone to challenge him.

Somewhere to go. Somewhere he could be himself, somewhere he could be cherished and challenged and grown and perfected. Somewhere he could be called out for his vices and admired for his virtues. Somewhere he could be the number one hero who surpassed All Might, somewhere he could be a bratty kid who thought too much of himself. No matter what happened.

No matter what happened.

That was why Izuku's dead eyes still haunted him.

"D… k…", he tried again.

He needed to give him his quirk back. It was the least he could do, after everything. Just in case.

And One For All was passed ahead through DNA, right? And his brain might not be working all that well in that moment, but he knew Izuku. He knew that, even if he *did* manage to say the words "please take my hair and eat it, you motherfucker" despite the lack of air in his lungs, the stubborn nerd *wouldn't* do it.

Not because he didn't want One For All back, of course, but because he would interpret the gesture as Katsuki giving up.

He would think Katsuki was passing his quirk back to him because he had accepted his defeat. He would think that risking All Might's legacy and allowing One For All to stay with Katsuki until he was rescued would be a motivation for him to keep fighting for his life. As if he would *ever* be a quitter.

He could almost hear Izuku's annoying little voice. *Keep it with you Kacchan, you can give it back to me when you're better*, yadda yadda yadda. Because Izuku was that person – he was optimistic. Too optimistic.

He was the one who always saw the silver lining in everything. He was the one who never gave up hope – who *forced* himself to never give up hope. And to always think positive. And Katsuki wasn't pessimistic, of course not, but he was realistic. And he knew that if he didn't pass One For All back to Deku, he would be risking putting an end to All Might's legacy. Because he was hurt pretty fucking badly, he couldn't feel his own face, and he was bleeding out all over Deku.

He was a determined person, but determination couldn't always solve everything. He had been fucking *impaled.* He *had* to face the facts: there was a very solid chance he wasn't going to make it, even if that knowledge terrified him out of his fucking mind. Even if he *wasn't* planning on giving up, no matter the odds that were against him.

But he couldn't risk burying All Might with him. *Or* Deku.

As a true hero, what he needed to do was: *prioritize rescue*. He wasn't giving up and embracing death, or any of that shit. But he was a smart person.

And he would be damned if he killed All Might's and Deku's legacy by dragging One For All with him to the grave.

Izuku leaned in closer to hear what he was trying to say, never ceasing to press on the injury that Katsuki couldn't feel anymore.

Katsuki didn't have many options. He couldn't move, *at all*. He couldn't yank a piece of his own hair and shove it inside Deku's mouth, because fuck knows what had become of his damn numb hands. He couldn't force the nerd to lick his blood, because not only would that be extremely gross and disgusting, but Deku would also most certainly deny it.

He could spit into Deku's mouth once he got close enough, but that would also be kind of gross, and things would only get really weird if he missed. He could only imagine Deku's reaction if the last thing he ever did before dying was downright spitting on his face. *Hah*. Also, Katsuki didn't think he was in the position of mustering any spare energy into spitting, since he couldn't even breathe properly. There *had* to be another way.

"What is it? Kacchan?", Izuku frowned at Katsuki's silence, worried.

Katsuki stared at him through one half-lidded eye. He was so close to him.

His eyes were so big and green. They had always been so expressive. Always telling Katsuki exactly what he was feeling, which was why the fake, forced smile never worked on him.

And to think he used to believe Izuku looked down on him. To think he'd been an idiot to the point of believing Deku would *ever* belittle him. Those seemed like the far away memories of a faraway boy who didn't know any better. A boy who was stupid, and arrogant, and self-centered, and who didn't know that there was so much more inside him than rage and anger.

A boy he would bury.

Izuku was really close, now. If he craned his neck, he would manage to brush his tongue against his and pass One For All back for him. That had to be enough, right? Enough saliva, enough DNA?

His thought process was very objective. In conclusion, he needed to pass One For All back to Izuku, and he could only do it through DNA. Since he was rendered immobile, the only way he could achieve that without asking for Izuku to take his quirk back – which he would probably misinterpret and deny – was if *he* did something. And his hands were useless in the moment, but his tongue was still mostly functional. And it also happened to be coated on his DNA.

Katsuki's heart skipped another beat. And another. It was starting to do that more frequently, actually. Which indicated he didn't have much time left.

He closed his eye. He didn't want to see Izuku's disappointed expression when he reached the faux conclusion that Katsuki was giving up. Because he *wasn't* giving up. But he also couldn't risk it.

He just couldn't risk it.

Also, he wanted to be rid of the damn thing already. It wasn't even his to begin with.

"Kacch–", Izuku tried to ask when Katsuki's eye slipped closed, fearing he had passed out again, but he was interrupted by Katsuki's mouth crashing against his.

Katsuki didn't open his eyes. All the energy he had left was put into lifting his head and brushing his tongue on Izuku's lips.

Izuku's lips were chapped and dry, probably because of all the dust covering him. Katsuki felt, more than heard, his little gasp of surprise, and took the opportunity to slip his tongue into his mouth. The only thing he could currently feel amidst all that numbness and cold was the warmth of Izuku's own tongue, which remained still as Katsuki's own curled against it.

Take it back. Take this shit back, I don't want it, I don't want it. It's yours. Take it back, take it back, take it back.

Katsuki hoped this would work and that One For All would go back to its true owner. He didn't really know if there was a proper way to pass it on – neither Izuku nor All Might had ever laid down the details of how this worked to him –, but he was *really* counting on his sheer will to get rid of the thing and give it back to Izuku to do the trick. And in a split moment of probable blood-loss-induced delusion, Katsuki found himself thinking that *this would probably still feel nice in another situation*.

His heart skipped again, barely managing to beat at all, and he didn't have the strength to keep his head up anymore. He collapsed back, but before his head snapped painfully against the concrete beneath it, Izuku held it, cradling it into his hands.

Both hands.

Katsuki didn't open his eyes. He didn't want to face Izuku after this. If anything, he didn't think he *could* open his eyes anymore, even if he wanted to. Everything was so heavy and numb…

He could feel his energy draining out of him faster than before, like water running down a sink. And he didn't have to regain his senses to realize damn Izuku was *no longer pressing down on his wound*.

"Midoriya…?", a familiar voice asked from afar, sounding so muffled and distant that Katsuki could have imagined it. Maybe he *was* imagining it. Maybe this was all a dream, and he was about to wake up any second now…

There was silence for a few moments. Katsuki was starting to wonder if he had passed out again or maybe died for good, when Izuku's voice filtered back into his only functional ear.

"You *bastard*", Izuku roared, and ok, Katsuki *had* to be asleep and dreaming, because he had never heard Izuku's voice sound so raw or his mouth produce such words. "You son of a – don't you *dare* do this".

Ok. So he had caught up with Katsuki's plan, and misinterpreted it as him giving up, *just* like he had imagined he would do.

Hah. Even nearly-dead, he had still outsmarted Izuku.

“You hear me? Don’t you *dare* give up, you idiot!”, Izuku screamed, but his voice was becoming more distant.

“Midoriya, stop!”

“Deku-kun, step away!”

“Kacchan! Are you listening to me? Do *not* do this!”

I’m not giving up, worm brain. Get on with the game.

“Midoriya, step away *now*. There’s no time for this”.

“Midoriya…”

“Kacchan!”

“Deku-kun –“

“*Kacchan* –!”

“Get away…”

“Ka…”

“…him float…”

“Steady –“

“Bakugou…”

“… coming in…”

“… losing him…”

“… Kaminari…”

“… god…”

“… again…”

“… clear…”

“… right now…”

“… to come down!”

“… wait up...”

“… *Detroit* –!“

The sound of a river flooded his ears.

Both of his ears.

He opened his eyes.

It took his vision a while to adjust, but the day was sunny and bright. The river water was cold against his bum, and legs, and feet. He was sitting in the water, pebbles digging hard against his skin.

One of his tiny childish hands supported his weight into a sitting position, while the other was outstretched upwards, holding on to another equally tiny, childish one. He looked up and found the child version of Izuku looking at him with concern, holding his hand into his.

Katsuki stared at him, confused.

“Am I dead?”, he asked, cringing at the unfamiliar sound of his child-voice. He took support in Izuku’s hand and pulled himself to his feet.

Izuku didn’t let go of his hand, even after Katsuki regained his balance.

“Not really”, Izuku shrugged, looking like he was about to cry.

“What the fuck does that mean?”, Katsuki frowned, making a blush rise to Izuku’s face.

“You shouldn’t swear, Kacchan”, Izuku reprimanded, looking away.

“Don’t tell me what to do”, Katsuki said, just because it was second-nature, offering tiny Izuku a lopsided grin. But tiny Izuku didn’t smile back.

His head was low, his eyes were downcast. Katsuki’s smile died.

“What?”, Katsuki frowned, confused.

Tiny Izuku didn’t meet his eyes.

“Just tell me what’s wrong”, Katsuki insisted, squeezing Izuku’s hand. He didn’t even find it in himself to deem it weird that he was holding it in the first place. If he wasn’t dead, why did Izuku look so sad?

Tiny Izuku took a deep breath, meeting his gaze.

“I need to let you go”.

Silence.

Katsuki narrowed his eyes.

“What?”

Tiny Izuku looked away, sadness etched in green.

“I need to let you go”, he repeated, meeting his gaze again.

Katsuki frowned, confused.

“I… I don’t get it”, he admitted, shaking his head.

Tiny Izuku took another deep breath.

“You gave me away, Kacchan. So I have to go”, he said miserably.

They stared at each other.

“You mean… One For All?”, Katsuki asked, hating how dumb he was sounding, asking all those questions.

Tiny Izuku nodded.

“This is a goodbye, but… Not forever”, tiny Izuku added. “I’ll always live within you, now”.

Katsuki frowned again.

“That sounds creepy as fuck, Deku”.

That finally urged a laughter out of the tiny Izuku, who sniffed before smiling up at him.

There was melancholy in his face, behind his smile.

“It’s just – that’s how One For All works. When a holder passes it on, they keep living within the quirk. But it also goes both ways. It means I’ll keep living within you, too. Just like All Might was still able to use it after he passed it on to me. I just… Won’t be as vivid as I am right now”.

Katsuki stared at him.

“So… Does that mean…”, he swallowed dry.

“Yes”, tiny Izuku nodded before he could continue. “You’ll keep living within me, too”.

Katsuki raised his eyebrows.

“That’s…”

“Please don’t swear again”.

A pause.

“I wasn’t going to say fucked up”.

“*Kacchan*”.

“What? I wasn’t going to say it”.

“But you just said it anyway”.

“So what?”

“So you’re a kid! Kids shouldn’t swear”.

“I always swore as a kid. Get your facts straight”.

“*Fine.* But you weren’t supposed to, anyway, so that’s still wrong”, Izuku sighed.

“Ok, you need to work on your definition of ‘wrong’, but let’s get to what matters – why are we even kids right now?”

Izuku shrugged, looking away. He seemed uncomfortable, out of a sudden.

“I think it’s because… I don’t know”, he worried at his lower lip. “This was it, wasn’t it?”

Katsuki stared at him, confused.

“This was *what*?”

Izuku sighed, meeting his eyes.

“The day when it all changed”, he said seriously, seeming upset.

Katsuki continued to stare. They were silent for a while.

He squinted his eyes to indicate his remaining confusion. Izuku sighed again, averting his eyes.

“The day when we started to stray from each other”, he clarified. “Because you always let me linger around you, even if you called me names or put me down. But after this day at the river, when you fell and I tried to help… That’s when you started to push me away for good”.

Katsuki stared down at their intertwined hands.

“And now…”, tiny Izuku continued. “We’re kind of… stuck together. Forever, in a way”, he shrugged again, looking up at Katsuki. “I think this is why we’re at this place. It’s a full circle”.

Katsuki frowned, but eventually nodded, his face serious. That made sense, sort of… But something about all that didn't quite sit right with him.

"What?", tiny Izuku asked.

"What's what?", he scoffed.

"You don't look so pleased".

Katsuki looked away, hating that he had shown that on his face.

A pensive pause.

"I don't know what to think", he admitted with a shrug.

"About what?", Izuku asked, patient.

Katsuki found his eyes.

"I don't know. About all this. Having your annoying little ghost inside me forever".

Izuku chuckled, tiny dimples appearing in his childish, freckly cheeks. He gave Katsuki a comprehensive smile before responding.

"If it's any consolation, your annoying little ghost will be inside me forever, too".

"That's no fucking consolation. Also, it's different".

"*How*?"

"I'm nowhere near as annoying as you are. If anything, you should be glad to have me around".

"*What*? Kacchan, you're *way* more annoying than I am!"

"Yeah, sure, keep telling yourself that".

Izuku laughed, but squeezed his hand again.

Katsuki looked at him. He was still smiling gently, but his eyes were honest. Serious.

"You don't have to worry about it, Kacchan", he said, tilting his head slightly. "We'll figure it out".

Katsuki looked away.

A pause. Meaningful, longer than the previous ones. For a while, all that could be heard was the watery flow of the river water and the far-away chirp of birds.

A cold breeze made both of their hairs flutter, and added to the coldness of the river water, it sent shivers down Katsuki's spine. They should probably get out of there and go back to

steady, dry ground, but for some reason, he couldn't move. He couldn't even let go of Izuku's hand.

"I didn't want to take your quirk", he admitted quietly, the words coming out naturally, with no effort or force.

Silence.

He looked up at Izuku, who was eyeing him with a puzzling look.

"I know", he nodded.

"So there's that", he scoffed, sniffed.

"What else is there?", Izuku encouraged.

Another pause.

"I didn't want to use it either", he completed.

Izuku nodded again.

"I know that, too".

"I didn't mean for it to happen", Katsuki continued, letting out a harsh breath. "I – I just knew I had to do something to save everyone, and it kind of – it –"

"Took over?", Izuku suggested.

Katsuki locked eyes with him.

"Yeah", he sniffed again. "And now I've marked it forever".

Izuku chuckled again, which made an offended look appear on Katsuki's face.

"So what?", he asked, lighthearted. "It's also marked you".

Katsuki bit his lower lip, shaking his head.

"Will it still be in me? Like it was in All Might?", he asked, not facing Izuku.

"What do you mean?"

"One For All", Katsuki swallowed dry. He looked at Izuku again. "All Might was still able to use it after he passed it to you. Well… At least he was until the Kamino thing", he glared at the river water, turning his face aside.

Izuku pondered a bit before he answered.

"A bit of it will live on within you", he settled for saying. "What you do with it is your choice".

Katsuki glared at him, suddenly annoyed. That look on a child's face did nothing to intimidate Izuku, though.

"This is the ghost quirk thing all over again", he complained, pissed off. "But there is no magical disconnecting us this time. We're stuck with each other forever, now".

Izuku gave him a sad smile, tilting his head.

"And what's so bad about that?"

Katsuki narrowed his eyes at him.

He tried to come up with an answer, mouth opening and closing, but he failed.

What *was* so bad about that?

Didn't Izuku feel like home? Hadn't he always been in his life?

Hadn't Katsuki always been in Izuku's life as well?

"I…", he said, face scrunched up in irritation. He huffed out another breath, glaring at Izuku. "I don't want any handouts".

Izuku frowned.

"What?"

Katsuki glared.

"What I achieve, what I conquer, I want to do that on my own", he explained. "But now, I'll never know if what I earned was actually *earned,* or if it happened because I was using your shitty quirk as a crutch".

Izuku blinked, but nodded.

"I… I see".

"Yeah, so what do I do about that? Huh?", Katsuki scoffed, suddenly angry. He had never even thought about the possibility that some of One For All would stay with him after he passed it back, like it had happened with All Might.

"You don't have to use it, Kacchan", Izuku said, defensive.

"I didn't mean to use it back at the explosion, either, but I did anyway", Katsuki pointed out. "In spite of myself".

"Because One For All was inside you", Izuku pointed out. "Now, you've passed it back to me. What's in you is just… embers".

"Embers?"

“Yes, embers”.

He narrowed his eyes again.

“That’s bullshit”.

“It’s not”, Izuku snorted. “That’ll be easier to control. Trust me, you won’t even know it’s in there unless you really search for it”.

Katsuki stared at him, suspicion appearing in his crimson eyes.

“Did you search for it?”

“Hm?”

“After I told you what I’d done”, he clarified. “After I told you you were quirkless again. Did you search for it?”

It was Izuku’s turn to look away.

“I did”, he admitted, shrugging. “I knew I wouldn’t be able to use it because I was still pretty weak and recovering, but… I… I tried to feel it”.

“And did you?”

Izuku met his eyes.

“Yes”, he nodded. “But it was really weak. Now I see why All Might could only keep his muscular form for a limited amount of time. But, even so, it didn’t feel…”

A pause.

“What?”

Izuku sighed.

“It didn’t feel like I’d be able to use it. To become a proper hero, I mean. It was… more like a lingering presence within me. Like a memory. Maybe it’s because I didn’t have it for as long as All Might did, I don’t know”, he shrugged, seeming embarrassed.

Katsuki scoffed, staring at him with an analytical look.

“And you’re ok with it?”, he squinted.

“With what?”, Izuku asked.

“With me, having these ‘embers’ or whatever in me, now”, Katsuki clarified.

Izuku shrugged, looking at him.

“I’d say so”.

Katsuki scoffed again, the sound dry and disbelieving.

“You’re *totally ok* with the fact that a part of *your* shitty quirk will live on within *me* forever?”, he raised his eyebrows at him.

Izuku looked away for a moment, pensive. Then, he looked back at Katsuki, sincerity overflowing from his green eyes. He looked serious.

“It’s ok if it’s you”.

Katsuki stared at him in silence. Trying to understand, trying to comprehend.

“Are *you* ok with it?”, it was Izuku’s turn to raise his eyebrows at him.

Truth was, he didn’t know. He really didn’t know. He had a lot of information to process, a lot of things to digest. He wasn’t sure he could find peace of mind knowing he had marked something so personally Izuku’s. Knowing he had left his little fingerprints all over his quirk – and that his quirk had also left its fingerprints all over him. *Forever*.

Knowing that that doubt would always nag at the back of his mind, provoking him, taunting him – the uncertainty regarding the purity of his accomplishments, the fear that his greatness would always have a bit of Izuku behind it. The fear that his success had been adulterated by Izuku’s quirk.

What a fucking mess.

“I guess I have to think about it”, he admitted, grumpy.

Izuku sighed, squeezing his hand again.

“Whatever is left of One For All in you will be so scarce that you won’t activate it unless you really, really try”, he tried to comfort him. “Especially because you’ve had it for less time than I did. Things will go back to the way they were before you had to take it. Well, except I’ll get my memories back, and it’ll be…”, a pensive pause. “Easier, I guess”.

Katsuki narrowed his eyes at him.

“When has shit ever been easy on us, Deku?”, he scoffed, the tiny hint of a smirk appearing on his lips.

Izuku sighed with a smile, nodding his head.

“Well, you’re right. But if it’s any consolation, I won’t be there as a ghost anymore. Like I said, I think it’ll be more like… a *feeling*”.

Katsuki raised his eyebrows at him.

“A *feeling*?”, he scoffed, mocking.

“Yes”, Izuku nodded. “Like feeling All Might and the previous holders within One For All”.

Katsuki frowned.

“I never felt them”.

Izuku mimicked his frown.

“You haven’t?”, he tilted his head to the side in curiosity.

“Well, I’ve *seen* a bunch of silhouettes, but I never talked to them or felt their presence. It’s only ever been you”.

Izuku stared at him with confusion for a moment before a warm, heartfelt smile blossomed on his lips.

“So it will stay that way”, he said, squeezing Katsuki’s hand. “You and me. Because it’s been like that since forever, right?”

Katsuki scoffed.

“Yeah, I guess”.

Izuku hummed.

“Yeah”.

Katsuki shrugged.

“Yeah”.

Another pause. The river continued to flow and the birds continued to chirp in the distance.

Katsuki continued to hold Izuku’s hand.

Izuku squeezed it again.

“It’s time”, he announced, serious but gentle.

Katsuki raised his head to look at him. Then, he noticed there was something off about the way Izuku wasn’t meeting his eyes.

He had a feeling there was something wrong.

“Why?”, he frowned, squeezing Izuku’s hand.

Izuku sighed, looking at him.

“I need to use One For All”, he said seriously.

That only made the frown on Katsuki’s face grow deeper.

“What? What’s going on?”, he asked.

“Too many people got in to rescue us, and Uraraka-san couldn’t keep all of the weight afloat. One of the boulders collapsed and disrupted the damaged structure. We’ll all be crushed to death if I don’t do something”.

Katsuki narrowed his eyes at him.

“How the hell do you know all this?”, he asked, suspicious.

Izuku sighed, a bit impatient.

“I’m still connected with you. Which is why you need to let me go”.

Katsuki continued to squint at him, waiting. Izuku sighed.

“Look”, he took Katsuki’s other hand into his own. “When you took One For All, you took *me* with it. This version of me has kept up with you and with what has happened to you, but the *real* me doesn’t have the access to that yet. That’s why he doesn’t remember anything from that month as a ghost – because it happened to me, not to him”.

Katsuki frowned.

“So you’re ghost Deku?”

Tiny Izuku shrugged.

“In a way, yes”.

“Stop saying this ‘in a way’ shit”, Katsuki snorted. “It’s pissing me off”.

Tiny Izuku gave him an amused sigh.

“It’s because it’s not that simple. To summarize it, you’re passed out right now, but I can still see what happens around you. I know what’s happening because I’m still connected to you, not because I’m connected with… the real me. Which I’m not. Yet”.

Katsuki tightened his lips, looking away.

“So you’ve been inside me this *whole* time?”

Izuku nodded.

“And you’ll stay inside me once I let you go?”

Izuku grimaced.

“Not really… I mean, yes, but not like this”.

“Then like *what*?”

“Like a feeling”, Izuku told him apologetically. “I’m sorry, I don’t know how to explain. You’ll understand when you feel it”.

Katsuki scoffed.

“If you were with me the whole time”, he said, angry. “Why the fuck didn’t you *talk* to me? If you saw all the shit that was happening? If you – If you *knew* –”

“Kacchan –“

“Why the fuck didn’t you tell me how to deal with your annoying ass? Why didn’t you – *do* something, or stop me from pushing you away?”

Izuku gave him a sad look.

“You don’t like being helped”, he said simply.

Katsuki fumed.

“Yeah, how *nice* of you to say that after you’ve literally tried to help me at *any* given opportunity despite what I liked! Fucking hypocrite”, he scowled.

“It’s not that simple, Kacchan”, Izuku tried to reason.

“Yeah, *nothing* is ever simple with you, is it, shithead?”

Izuku sighed.

“The reason I never appeared to you is because you hadn’t used One For All. If anything, you were repressing it inside you. I was… I was *dormant* within you. You’re seeing me right now because you used it, *and* because you’re dying. I couldn’t have appeared as vividly to you before if it wasn’t a moment of crisis, like right after the building collapsed”.

Katsuki frowned.

“That was you?”

“Yes”, Izuku nodded.

“*Why*?”

“Because you needed to hold on until the real me arrived”.

Katsuki scoffed.

“I wasn’t going to give up and die if you hadn’t been there to pep-talk me, Deku. You think way too much of yourself”.

Izuku tilted his head to the side, silent.

A pause. Katsuki looked at him and narrowed his eyes.

“I *wasn’t*”, he added, vehement.

“I didn’t want to risk it”, Izuku retorted, defensive.

Katsuki snorted.

“You and your goddamn hero complex –“

“I *wasn’t* going to risk it”, Izuku interrupted him.

They stared at each other.

“I –“, Izuku said, swallowing dry. “Ever since you took One For All from me, I was there with you. But it’s not as simple as you think. I wasn’t – listening to your every conversation, I wasn’t spying on you, I wasn’t – I wasn’t nosing around. I just existed. I was just there”.

Katsuki glared at him.

Deku had always been there… He had always been a constant in his life. Even when Katsuki ignored him, he had always been there to wish him a good morning. Even when Katsuki mistreated him, he had always been there to praise him.

More silence. Izuku squeezed his hands, meaningful – trying to reassure him, and make him understand.

Katsuki glared away, at the river water.

“So when you go back to him – he’ll finally remember?”

Izuku nodded.

“Yes”.

Katsuki looked at him from the corners of his eyes.

“Everything?”

“Everything”, Izuku nodded again.

Katsuki snorted out a humorless laugh, shaking his head slightly.

“That changes things”.

Tiny Izuku nodded.

“For better, wouldn’t you say?”

Katsuki scoffed, smiling for a second before going back to grimacing grumpily.

“Don’t know”, he admitted. Then, he glared at Izuku. “Guess we’ll have to figure it out as we go”.

Izuku nodded, serious.

Then, after a pause, he bit his lower lip, hesitant.

“Hey. Can I… Ask you something?”

Katsuki looked at him.

“What?”

Izuku bit his lower lip.

“Don’t push me away again?”, he swallowed dry. “I mean, I know it’s hard for you. To be open with your feelings, and all that”, he smiled sadly, sniffing, before squeezing both of Katsuki’s hands again. “I remember it. From when we were stuck together. But I also know you’re getting better at it”, the smile reached his eyes. “And I know that… this whole day…”, he shook his head.

A brief silence.

“It wasn’t easy for me”, he concluded.

Katsuki watched him.

“Guess we’re even on the trauma, right?”, he snorted eventually. “Oh, no, wait. I still beat you on 2 to 1 in the ‘having to watch a near-death experience’ category”.

Izuku gave him a disapproving look.

“Do you have to be so competitive all the time?”

“Yeah”, Katsuki shrugged and nodded.

“I’m serious”, Izuku said. “Can we please agree to just talk this out when neither of us are dying?”

“Talk *what* out, Deku?”, Katsuki sighed tiredly.

Silence.

“*Everything*, Kacchan”, Izuku frowned, disbelieving. “We have a lot to figure out”.

“Do we?”, Katsuki stared at him.

Izuku squinted.

“*Yes*”, he said, almost offended. “We spent six months without talking to each other. We can’t just go back to the way things were before. I don’t *want* to go back to the way things were before, and you know very well why”.

Katsuki locked his jaw. Izuku looked very serious.

“Can we agree or can’t we?”, Izuku asked, letting go of one of Katsuki’s hands and raising his pinky finger at him.

Katsuki rolled his eyes, scoffing.

“*This* again?”

“We’re kids, so it’s appropriate”, Izuku shrugged, pinky still raised. He raised his eyebrows at Katsuki.

Katsuki glared at him.

He intertwined his pinky finger with Izuku’s before letting go.

“*Fine*”, he huffed out. “But no lashing out at me and running away just because I care about you”.

“Only if you agree not to treat me like I’m made of porcelain. Or like I’m incompetent. *Or* like I’m an idiot”.

“But you *are* an idiot”, Katsuki scoffed, smirking. Izuku narrowed his eyes at him.

“You see, that’s what I’m talking about”.

“You should know by now I don’t actually mean it”, Katsuki rolled his eyes in annoyance.

“Oh, *don’t* you?”, Izuku gave him a disbelieving look.

“Fine, only sometimes. But you can hardly blame me, since you literally ran into a collapsed building that was about to crash. Like an *idiot* would do”.

“Because you were in there”.

“You trying to blame me for your stupidity?”, Katsuki snorted, amused.

“Wouldn’t you have done the same if it was me in there?”

Katsuki scowled at him, jaw locked, annoyed by the truth behind the words.

He sighed compliantly.

“*Fine*. We can talk this out without pissing each other off”.

“Good”, Izuku nodded. “You’d better keep that promise, because I don’t think I’ll remember any of this interaction”.

Katsuki frowned.

“What? Why not?”

“Because you already passed One For All back to me”, Izuku explained. “I’m just… a *ghost* of myself”, he smiled.

Katsuki rolled his eyes and groaned.

“*Seriously*?”

“C’mon, it was funny”.

“No”.

“Not even a little bit?”

“Ugh”.

A melancholic pause. Izuku smiled sadly at him.

“But I mean it. I don’t think any of this will be in my memory when I go back. This part of me that’s talking to you now… It’ll stay here”, he placed a hand atop Katsuki’s chest, right above his heart. “So… Just talk to me when you’re back. Because I’ll be pretty terrified and worried and I’ll need you to be frank. Ok?”

Katsuki gazed into those green eyes.

“Ok”, he shrugged, looking away again. “But if you do remember all this shit, you’d better tell me”.

“Of course I will”, Izuku promised.

Katsuki glared at him.

“I’m *serious*”.

“Me too”, he nodded, frowning a bit.

“No faking amnesia just to force me into talking about my shitty feelings”.

Izuku blinked.

“I’d never do that to you, Kacchan”.

They stared at each other.

Katsuki hummed and looked away.

“So… How do I do this?”, he asked.

“You let go of my hand”, Izuku said.

“Just like that?”

“Just like that”.

Katsuki narrowed his eyes at him.

“How do you even know?”

Izuku chuckled.

“I just do”.

“But *how*? This shit has never happened to you before. Or has it?”, he frowned.

“No”, Izuku shook his head. “I have never interacted with past holders like this. In my defense, I had never passed One For All on to anyone as well. But I do think there’s something different about us”.

“Why?”, Katsuki squinted.

Izuku blushed.

“Well, All Might has never spoken of anything like this. I don’t think any of the past holders have gone through this, either. I think it’s because it’s us”, he shrugged, not meeting Katsuki’s eyes. “And the connection we share”.

Katsuki stared at him.

“You mean the soulbond?”

“That, too”, Izuku nodded.

Katsuki narrowed his eyes.

“What else?”

Izuku smiled, lowering his head.

“Everything, Kacchan”, he shrugged, sounding tired. He locked eyes with Katsuki. “The lifetime we share”.

A pause.

“Truth is, I don’t think I can imagine life without you”, Izuku admitted sadly, shrugging again.

His green eyes locked with Katsuki’s. The phantom of a smile was still tinging his lips, but his gaze was miserable. Like he didn’t expect Katsuki to correspond, but like he was also too fed up to care and hide his feelings any longer.

And Katsuki… Katsuki still felt constrained, in a way. Restricted. But feeling fed up was also a sentiment he could share.

And who was he kidding? The only reason why they spent months without talking was because Katsuki cared about Izuku. Way too much.

And because a life without Izuku, despite all odds, was the nightmare that still plagued him the most.

“I can’t imagine it, either”, he muttered under his breath, head tilted away.

Izuku frowned.

“Huh?”

Katsuki sighed.

“A life without you”, he said more loudly, awkward, and not meeting Izuku’s eyes. “I can’t imagine it, either. But don’t think so much of yourself”, he added out of habit.

Izuku smiled fondly.

“Hey, Kacchan”, he called.

Katsuki looked at him.

“I really hope I remember this”, he admitted.

Katsuki scoffed.

“Tell me about it”.

Izuku hesitated.

“But if I don’t”, he continued. “Do you mind telling me again?”

Katsuki looked away.

“I’ll think about it”.

“Mean”, tiny Izuku fake-pouted.

Katsuki snorted humorously, locking eyes with him.

Their hands were still intertwined, and he still hadn’t let go. Izuku looked down at their locked hands, then back at Katsuki.

“Why are you stalling this?”, Izuku asked, sounding genuinely curious.

Katsuki wanted to yell at him for suggesting that, but deep down… He knew Izuku was right. He *was* stalling.

“I don’t know”, he shrugged, glaring at his feet. “Guess it took me so long to finally take your damn, sticky hand that I just can’t let go now. They must be fucking glued or

something”.

Izuku chuckled.

“My hand’s not sticky”.

“Yes, it is”.

“Kacchan”, he called tenderly.

Katsuki looked at him.

“It will be all right. We have a lot to talk about, and a lot to figure out, but… Everything will be fine”.

Katsuki scoffed, jaw locked. His averted his eyes and his head downward again, unable to meet Izuku’s gaze anymore. It was too overwhelming.

“Will you try to remember?”, he asked, hating how childish he ended up sounding – even if he *was* a child in that moment.

“I promise I’ll try”, Izuku told him, squeezing his hand. “This moment, I mean. I’m sure I will remember everything else”.

Katsuki scoffed.

“Bet this talk will be awkward as shit”.

“It doesn’t have to be”.

Katsuki rolled his eyes, still not looking at Izuku.

“It *always* is when it comes to shitty feelings”.

“Actually, I don’t think so”, Izuku said. “In the rare moments when you let your other feelings out, you can be very honest”.

Katsuki gritted his teeth.

“So just keep being honest, ok? And I’ll be honest too”.

Silence.

“Hey, Kacchan”, Izuku called.

Katsuki continued to stare at his feet, shaking his head softly.

“Can you let me go?”, Izuku asked, gentle.

Could he?

“*Fine*”, Katsuki huffed out with annoyance, letting go of Izuku’s hand. “But if you think –“

Whatever he was about to say died in his tongue as he raised his head.

Izuku was no longer there.

His child self was standing alone there, in the middle of the river. He looked around, searching all angles for Izuku, but he was no longer there.

Katsuki was alone.

He looked up at the sky. It was no longer sunny and bright, but pitch black, just a few, scarce stars shining amidst the darkness. And as he looked around, he was no longer a child standing in a river, but a teenager impaled on a piece of metal and dying from blood loss.

The last thing he saw from his glassy, one-eyed vision was green lightning. Then, darkness overcame him again.

“*– Smash!”*

Chapter End Notes

Happy birthday Bakugou lmao

I think this was definitely my favorite chapter to write so far, so many angsty moments and pain and confusion and fear... (chef's kiss). Also I really loved to explore the whole hand-symbolism thing I've been building up in this story, the fingers reaching out, the fingertips brushing the exit just before Bakugou is (quite literally) blown away, just like he never quite manages to reach Deku for real... And how having them grab each other's hand symbolizes they're finally going back into tune :-)

I do hope the whole kids-in-the-river scene didn't turn out too cheesy? Idk. I'm just... I also adore the idea that now they'll live on within each other, just like All Might could still use OFA after he passed it on to Deku.

Agh. I just want them to finally make up and properly make out.Do you guys think Bakugou even realized that what he did was basically to kiss Deku, rather than just pass OFA back to him? Hahahaha... did... did he realize...? Does he... like... know... that was a kiss...?

Anyway. Next chapter will FINALLY put the comfort in the hurt/comfort tag. I did tell you guys it would happen eventually! I should warn, however, that it might take a while longer to come out (for some personal reasons).

As always, thanks so much for reading and keeping up with this story and being as lovely as you always are <3 Stay safe, take care, and I'll see you guys next chapter!

Chapter 26: Kiksuya

Chapter Notes

Hey, guys! Just some quick warnings before you start reading this one:

1. This is long af (sorry);
2. There is a vivid description of a panic attack in it, so please be safe. It's more detailed than the one from the beginning of the story and it's explicitly addressed as a panic attack (the one in the earlier chapters was only speculated as such);
3. There is a long section that consists only of flashbacks by the end of this chapter (just warning because I know that's not everyone's cup of tea). While most of the segment is a repetition of things that happened in previous chapters, the three final flashbacks bring a different POV to the story, so you might be interested in not skipping those;
4. I know this took forever and I know most of you haven't been updated on what's going on because of my twitter freakout, so I'm sorry. There's a deeper explanation about all this in the end notes;
5. This is not what some of you may have had in mind or expected for this chapter, but I hope you still enjoy it!

Happy reading!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

When Katsuki woke up, he didn't remember what had happened to him.

There was some sort of bandage enveloping his head and a constant, dull throbbing making it hard for him to focus on his surroundings, and when he finally dared to blink his eyes open, the bright light sent a stab of pain across his skull. He hissed loudly, squeezing his lids shut and grinding his teeth. God, he hated concussions.

He didn't remember how he had gotten himself concussed, though, which was why he attempted to open his eyes again. Knowing what to expect this time, the pain wasn't so unbearable. He blinked his crimson eyes several times until they finally regained focus, and found himself staring up at the unmistakable ceiling of a hospital.

Déjà vu hit him like a ton of bricks, but he didn't really know why.

The first thing he noticed was that he was alone in the room. Which was… weird. Not that he needed anyone to keep him company, but he would really like it if someone was there to explain what had gotten him into this mess this time. He tried to tilt his head to the side and get a better look at his surroundings, only then noticing that: 1. His head was aching a *lot* more now that he moved it; 2. There was a nasal cannula strapped to his face; and 3. He was thirsty as fuck.

He groaned, squeezing his eyes shut again and trying to find his voice. His throat was really, really dry. Other than that, and the fact that his head felt like mashed potato, he seemed to be fine.

He waited for a few moments, trying to listen for anyone coming in. The room was very quiet – in a way that was almost eerie. Katsuki was pretty sure he should be hearing the beeping of a heart monitor, the whirring of a machine, the clock ticking. Something. *Anything.*

His heart sped up at the intrusive thought that appeared in his brain. That… That his hearing…

His eyes darted across the room again, finding the door. Next to it was a glass wall with pulled-up blinders. The wall was probably see-through to allow the nurses to see if he was in trouble or doing something he shouldn't, and the blinders were probably a counter measure to offer him some privacy if needed. From what Katsuki could see, this seemed to be a fancy hospital – at least the structure and the lighting gave him that impression.

He kept staring at the door and at the wall, hoping that the few scarce people who walked past the room would arrive and confirm that he hadn't lost his hearing for good, or at least tell him what had put him into that bed. But the longer he waited, the less people walked by – and none of them paid him any mind.

He sighed. He was awake, now, right? He could just… Go ask someone. Or, better: he could go fetch himself a glass of water. That would help clear his sluggish brain, right? Sure, his head was throbbing and his throat was dry, but he could manage getting to his feet and grabbing something to drink. No big deal. He shouldn't lie around and wait for someone to rescue him like an idiot, after all.

Without really thinking about it, he tried to grab the thin hospital sheets covering him and toss them aside to free his legs, only to find that he… couldn't…?

Katsuki tried to swallow, even if his mouth was as dry as the Sahara Desert, and tilted his head to look down at his body. His neck and the back of his skull protested vehemently at the movement – in fact, so viciously that he saw black spots for a moment. When his vision cleared and he blinked his eyes, he finally noticed that his arms were covered in two perfectly white casts, all the way from his elbows to his bandaged fingers.

What the fuck…?

Flashes of Kaminari's face, half-covered in blood and looking desperate, staring down at him and yelling something he couldn't hear appeared in his increasingly frantic mind. Deku's face flashed in his memory, too. He had also been bleeding, and crying.

Shit. *Shit.*

The museum. The villains. The… The bomb…

Had the building exploded and collapsed? Was anyone other than him hurt? The answer to that was yes, right? Because he could remember Kaminari's and Deku's bleeding faces now,

he could remember that Jirou had been bleeding too, and an explosion like that was sure to have sent more people to the hospital.

Shit. Everything had happened so fast, back then, he didn't even have the time to spare a thought to the people standing right outside the building. And now they were probably hurt too.

And also, there – there was Hatsume, and Jirou, and Sero, and Mina – had he gotten them out? Were they safe? Had Sero managed to grab them all and save them before they plummeted to their deaths? Why was he fucking alone in this shitty room with no one to tell him what had happened to his friends?

Katsuki decided he needed answers, and he needed them right away. How could he just lie there compliantly when he didn't know if Deku was alive? If his *friends* were alive? If someone else was hurt? How could he relax and wait for someone to walk by and see him awake by luck, when he couldn't even remember what had happened to him? No, he couldn't do that. He couldn't just wait. Plus, his throat was so dry he was sure the skin would break and bleed if he even thought of attempting to scream for a nurse.

He kicked the blankets away until he freed his legs, which seemed to be miraculously unbroken – unlike his arms and hands. In an impulse, he sat up and threw his feet off the hospital bed with one swift movement, meaning to get the answers to his damn questions. He stood up, determined.

And then he immediately collapsed to the floor.

It was all pretty confusing, really. How his knees buckled so easily beneath his weight, how his entire body felt like melting jelly as soon as he put his weight to his feet. How the floor seemed to rise to meet his face, rather than him falling off to meet the floor. How a hot, searing pain erupted in his torso as soon as his body collapsed, how his vision went black all the way as soon as his skull thudded sharply with the cold ground, since he couldn't use his arms to break his fall.

He just laid there for a while, inert, trying to breathe through the sudden pain and struggling really hard against the sudden will to vomit. He wasn't sure if he even had anything in his stomach to be brought up, or if he had the strength to try and retch. All his determination to get water and get answers seeped off him like dispersing steam, and then he was just an injured boy fallen on a hospital floor.

"For *god's* sake", an uncharacteristically exasperated voice exclaimed suddenly for somewhere above him. Despite the angry tone directed at him, Katsuki's body immediately relaxed at the sound – it was muffled, like he was hearing it through many layers of cloth, but that meant that he could still hear from one of his ears.

The world spun in a whirlpool of colors, blue and white dancing together and twisting and spinning in a dizzying way, which didn't do wonders for his growing nausea. He couldn't really comprehend what was happening or why everything was so confusing and the pain was so intense –

When he opened his dizzy eyes, he found the ceiling again. It took a few moments for it to stop spinning. Once it became still, he blinked.

Huh?

Had it… Had it all been a dream?

What was happening to him? His eyes darted around the room nervously, trying to come up with answers. He couldn't tell for sure whether or not he had been dreaming, which was quite frankly making him nervous. But then his eyes found a very tired-looking Aizawa standing beside him, by his bed, arms crossed above his chest and reprehension on his face.

"I leave you alone for five minutes and you immediately find your way to trouble again?", he scolded with a disapproving look, but there was something else to it. Something Katsuki couldn't really put his finger on. Before he could say anything, Aizawa placed the nasal cannula back on his face, and only then did Katsuki realize it must have been ripped off when he fell.

He only became aware of how hard it was becoming to breathe when the oxygen was forced back into him. He sighed, too tired and pained to pretend he wasn't relieved by what the cannula was offering him. A small voice at the back of his head was screaming for him not to let his guard so down, but there was something preventing him from caring or worrying about what Aizawa would think – something smothering his inhibitions and allowing him to just… relax.

He opened his mouth to speak, but his lips were so dry they felt like they were about to crack. Apparently noticing this – and noticing there was no sounding coming off Katsuki's parted lips –, Aizawa merely sighed and looked at something over his shoulder.

"Wait. I'll fetch you some ice chips".

Then he was gone.

Katsuki wanted to scoff in disdain. He didn't want fucking *ice chips*. He could drink proper water like a normal person, thanks very much. Plus, he was so goddamn thirsty that he was sure ice chips would have no effect. He wanted real water. Water he could chug on. Water he could down in one go and relieve his aching throat…

Aizawa returned with a plastic cup in hands, giving Katsuki a very serious look as he picked one of the chips with a bright pink plastic catcher. Katsuki realized that he had been on the verge of drifting off, and blinked his eyes back into alertness before he succumbed back to sleep. Huh, weird.

"I need to know you are listening to me and can understand what I'm saying", Aizawa said, stern.

Katsuki frowned, but nodded briefly after a few moments. His head ached.

“Good”, Aizawa nodded back. “You underwent a very complicated 12-hour-long surgery. I can tell from the look on your face that you’re about to complain about me feeding you these ice chips, but my advice is: don’t bother. You can’t drink proper water just yet because of the surgery and I bet your throat feels like sandpaper. Both your arms are in a cast, so you can’t eat this by yourself. If I were you, I would just take this without complaint, unless you’re in the mood for staying in this hospital for longer than you need to”.

Katsuki stared at him, feeling a hot blush rise to his cheeks. It took him longer than he should have to understand everything, but once he did, he felt like scowling and complaining, and probably telling something very disrespectful to his sensei.

But deep down, he knew the man was right. From the searing, throbbing pain burning his torso, Katsuki didn’t find it that hard to believe that yeah, a surgery definitely happened there. He wished he could remember why it had happened, though… But in the end, his teacher was right – it wouldn’t be safe to chug on a gallon of water (like he wanted to) that soon after operating.

He really fucking hated hospitals. If allowing his teacher to feed him ice chips, no matter how humiliating that was, would mean he’d get to leave that place faster, he would do it. He figured he could set his pride aside for a little while. Also, he was pretty fucking thirsty, and it wasn’t like he could do it on his own anyway…

(Something told him he should feel angry about that, but he just… Didn’t. Which was really weird, considering how worried and determined he had been just a few moments before.)

Katsuki looked away in slight embarrassment but nodded briefly, glaring at the wall.

“Good”, was Aizawa’s only response before placing one of the ice chips against Katsuki’s lips.

Katsuki opened his mouth compliantly, feeling like a stupid child. He tried not to think about how pathetic he ended up feeling anyway, despite his relaxation, before sucking greedily on the chip.

His negative feelings of shame and embarrassment were almost completely eradicated in the face of the sheer relief that overwhelmed him as soon as the ice melted and ran down his dry, sore throat. *Almost.*

Katsuki closed his eyes and sighed, relishing on the feeling. It even became easier to breathe, now that his entire mouth didn’t feel like a wasteland. Aizawa fed him another ice chip, and another, and another, and another, until Katsuki felt a bit more like a human being again. Once he was satisfied, he allowed himself to meet his teacher’s eyes, still embarrassed but a bit more grateful.

“Done?”, Aizawa asked simply, reading the look on his face as if it was an open book. Katsuki felt a bit exposed by his teacher’s ease at figuring out what he was thinking, but it was also… comforting, somehow? At least he didn’t have to do much talking, because he was feeling pretty worn out.

He nodded, and Aizawa silently disappeared with the plastic cup. He was back almost immediately.

Instead of saying anything or even scolding him for trying to escape his bed, Aizawa simply grabbed his sheets, tucked him in again, and reached forwards to pressed a button above Katsuki's bed. Upon Katsuki's confused frown, he explained, in the same monotone as ever:

"You tore your IV when you fell. I'm calling the nurse to fix it".

Huh. Katsuki hadn't even felt that. He supposed everything else felt dull in comparison to the fire in his torso and the throbbing in his head. The pain was starting to feel a bit better, now that he was back to bed, but it was still… unsettling. Especially because Katsuki couldn't remember what had caused it.

He couldn't remember much after throwing his friends out of the building, really. He knew Deku's and Kaminari's bloodied faces had been there somewhere, at some point… Had that been during his rescue? And were they ok? Were his friends? Was Hatsume? Where were they?

Oh, yes. Right. That was why he had gotten up in the first place.

He mentally cursed himself for forgetting, because that was important… But he was also feeling so lightheaded, and sluggish, and… drifty… He had been feeling that way ever since he woke up. Maybe they had drugged him? If he went through surgery, that meant he must have needed painkillers and sedation and that sort of stuff… Maybe that was what was making his brain melt. Katsuki decided he hated it. Now that he thought about it, he felt like an idiot. A slurring, stuttering, blabbering idiot.

He didn't need those brain-melting drugs, he needed answers. He needed to know what had happened to him, to his friends, and to his ears. That was all that mattered. And he needed to *focus*. He turned to Aizawa again, who was patiently waiting by his bedside, and the teacher looked about to tell him something –

"Oh, I see our patient is awake!", a foreign voice said cheerfully from the door, immediately sending a wave of annoyance across Katsuki's entire being. He didn't even know this person, but the happy-go-lucky tone in her annoying squeaky voice was enough to make him cringe.

He glared, out of instinct, as a nurse closed the blinders of the glass wall and approached the bed. The last thing Aizawa told him, in a hushed tone, before stepping away to give the nurse space, was a quick and almost-threatening "*Behave*".

The nurse turned the room's lights on, and if Katsuki had thought it had been *bright* when he first woke up, that was nothing compared to now. He had to screw his eyes shut at the immense clarity and slowly reopen them until they grew accustomed to the brightness, which only made his hatred for the cheery nurse become more intense. She couldn't have fucking warned him that she was about to put a spotlight on his face?

Katsuki glared up at the nurse, who was checking his chart and the machines surrounding the bed. She kept humming to herself while she did that, which definitely didn't do much to

increase Katsuki's sympathy for her. Once she was satisfied with what she had read, she offered Katsuki a clearly exaggerated smile.

"So, how are we feeling today?", she asked sweetly, sounding genuinely interested in his answer. She approached him and pulled a tiny flashlight off her coat's pocket. This time, Katsuki had a few seconds to brace himself before she turned it on and shone the light into his eyes, checking his pupils.

He didn't dignify her with a response. Instead, he merely turned his head away once she was done checking his eyes and glared at the wall, willing the woman to just do what she had to do and get the hell lost so that he could talk to his teacher alone.

"Not so talkative, huh, hun?", she said with sympathy, putting the flashlight away. "At least your concussion seems to be better. Soon enough you'll be good as new!"

Katsuki just scoffed in response. For some reason, this woman's antics were driving him up the walls, and it seemed that being driven up the walls was making him think more clearly.

Sensing his reluctance to interact, Aizawa stepped back into the scene with an almost disappointed sigh.

"He woke up just a few minutes ago. I went out for a moment to use the bathroom and when I came back, he was on the floor. He tore his IV in the process. I already gave him some ice chips".

The nurse stared at the floor at Aizawa's words, noticing the fallen IV and the bloodied needle. She bent down and picked it up.

"I see", the nurse nodded at the teacher, approaching Katsuki on the bed. She checked the thin trail of blood on his arm, where IV needle used to be, before checking the needle itself with a frown. She examined his arm to see if any damage was done and then wiped the blood away with a cotton.

"Hm, this will bruise and may be a little sore for a while, but it's not a big deal", she commented as she grabbed fresh equipment to stick him with a new, clean IV drip. "But my, my, dear, what you did was very dangerous. You were lucky the needle came off your arm when you fell; if it had broken inside you, it could have entered your bloodstream and killed you in a matter of minutes", she commented pensively, with a sort of medical curiosity in her tone. She tapped his arm to get the vein for the IV and then stuck the needle into it without warning.

Katsuki stopped glaring at the wall to glare at her instead. He hated – absolutely hated – being babied like that, especially by people who he didn't know and who sounded as condescending and fake as this woman. How could she possibly be this cheerful and easy-going if her job was to aid dying people all day long? And why the hell did she keep doing stuff without warning him about it first?

Aizawa looked slightly uncomfortable by the nurse's comment on his possible death, which was delivered with such ease, but for those who didn't know him all that well, he seemed as

stoic as ever. He must have noticed Katsuki's growing, boiling anger, however, because soon enough he cleared his throat, arms still crossed above his chest, and took another step closer to the bed.

"Is it already time for another dose of his… medication?", he asked.

Katsuki stared at him, feeling a bit suspicious by the way his teacher had said "medication". Also, while he kind of hated that Aizawa was speaking and making decisions on his behalf, he was also a bit grateful for that. He wasn't in the mood for interacting with the damn annoying nurse and, if he had to be honest, he *was* in pain. And it was growing. Maybe medication wouldn't go amiss, but he wasn't about to admit that. Perhaps he owed his teacher a thanks for picking up on that and trying to fix it himself.

"Oh, let me check that", she got back to her feet, disappearing somewhere in the room.

He locked eyes with Aizawa, trying to read his teacher's face and to figure out why he had said "medication" like that, but before his slow brain could get too far the nurse returned.

"All right, I can give him another dose already. That was probably why the poor thing woke up in the first place", the nurse commented with pity in her tone.

Katsuki glared daggers at her, rage burning deep into his chest. He wasn't a *poor thing*, and he didn't need this woman's pity. She didn't even *know* him. The room seemed to sharpen around him.

"Yeah, except I wasn't in pain when I woke up", he spat, his tone snappy and rude.

Also, to his horror, he realized he sounded like *shit*. Pure shit. As if someone had yanked his vocal cords out, thrown them in a blender, and shoved them back into his throat. What the *hell*.

The nurse seemed a bit taken aback by his not-so-kind first words to her, or maybe she was just surprised by how terrible he sounded. Aizawa, on the other hand, simply sighed.

"Bakugou", he said, his voice too tired to be properly reprehensive. "Let her do her job".

"Uh, yes, all right", the nurse nodded, a bit quieter, now. "I'll just need to examine him first, to make sure he didn't aggravate his injuries", she added in a professional tone.

She had probably sensed that Katsuki wasn't the kind of person to try and put on a smile for her just because she was playing nice, and decided it would be better to get down to business already rather than to try and urge a conversation out of him.

Good.

Katsuki didn't look at her while she worked, too humiliated and angry for that. The alien relaxation and easiness he had felt a few moments before was eradicated from his system now.

The nurse had to lift a bit of his hospital gown, enough to reveal the injury site but nothing else that could be too… *compromising*, but he still blushed in embarrassment. He was glad that Aizawa had at least turned his back and stepped away before she started, staring out the window instead.

"Does that hurt, dear?", she asked gently while prodding and poking at his at his side and at his ribs. He gritted his teeth and refused to respond, but couldn't suppress a pained groan when she pressed the sore area in his abdomen.

He refused to look at her face, knowing that he would only find sympathy and pity there and that, if he saw it, he would only be even more pissed. She hummed pensively at his non-verbal response, and stepped away.

"Well", she said, lowering his gown again and grabbing his chart. She tucked him into his sheets and pressed a button Katsuki couldn't see from where he was lying down.

She was addressing Aizawa, rather than Katsuki, seemingly giving up on interacting with him. Sensing this, his teacher turned away from the window, looking at her.

"He seems to be fine", the nurse smiled encouragingly. "Or, at least as fine as he could be, given what happened. Falling down didn't disrupt his injuries, thankfully, but it was about time for his next dose of meds, so I just hit him up. He'll start feeling drowsy in a while. His doctor will be here after lunch time to make a follow up and check on him, but there's not much we can do for now other than keep an eye on him and let him rest. Oh, you need to keep him from getting out of bed again. If you need to leave, let me know so I can call someone –"

"I'll be staying, thank you", Aizawa cut her off with a deadpan, arms crossed above his chest. The nurse stared at him – probably wondering if Katsuki's manners and his teacher's were related.

"Oh. Right. I see", the nurse blinked, a bit awkward. "But… If you *absolutely* need to leave, let the staff know so they can send someone in. Buzz me again if you need anything, all right?"

"All right", he nodded. Then, he bowed slightly: "Thank you".

The nurse offered him a small smile.

"No problem", she said, bowing in return before walking away.

The door to the room clicked softly, indicating the nurse's departure.

Aizawa walked around the bed so that he would be standing in Katsuki's direct field of vision, arms still crossed above his chest and a serious look lingering on his face.

He simply stared at Katsuki for a few moments, looking like he was trying to read him – analyzing him. After a few seconds of awkward silence, he walked to the corner of the

hospital room, grabbed himself an uncomfortable-looking plastic chair, dragged it towards the bed, and sat down beside Katsuki.

Fine. If he wanted to ask about stuff, this was the time. Before whatever drugs the nurse had given him started making him sleepy again.

“Why’re you stayin’?”, Katsuki asked his teacher, flinching at the sound of his own voice. Not only was it cracking and croaking, but his speech was also slurred, as if he was drunk. He had to admit – those were some fast fucking meds.

Aizawa didn’t look impressed by this.

“We don’t know if the villains behind the attack are part of a bigger group. While the investigation is in progress, you must be watched during all times”, he provided objectively. “We don’t want any of them coming after you for revenge or to finish the job”, he added.

Katsuki frowned, but nodded. That made sense. There *could* have been more villains in the group, and it would make sense if they were driven to seek revenge against the guy who ruined their plans. But one thing was still bothering him about the explanation.

“But why’re *you* stayin’?”, he mustered, still hating his voice. The frown on his face deepened.

Aizawa sighed, sagging back against the chair’s rest.

“Given how often you seem to get yourself into potentially deadly situations, I decided I’d feel better if I watched you myself”, he provided. “Just in case”.

Katsuki stared at him.

“I’m also sure you’ll know to behave towards the staff while I’m around”, he added with only the hint of a warning in his tone. “You did give them a lot of trouble when you first arrived”.

That stirred Katsuki’s curiosity towards what the fuck had happened to him after the explosion, but he had more pressing worries at hands. He needed to go one step at the time, no matter how eager he was to catch up with everything.

“Where’s Deku?”, he croaked, grimacing as he tried to find a more comfortable position on the bed and failed. “An’ Jirou, ‘n’ Sero, Mina, H’tsume?”

Aizawa studied his face.

“They’re all fine”, he said, sounding as if he didn’t want to go into too many details just yet. “There’s no reason to worry about them”.

Katsuki kept staring at him, waiting for the man to go on. Aizawa looked like he had secretly rolled his eyes by blinking for a bit too long.

“How much do you remember?”, he asked, monotone. Katsuki searched his brain again.

“Up ‘til throwin’ them out”, he slurred. “Blew up th’wall and shov’d them ‘way”.

Aizawa nodded.

“That was a very quick thinking of you. I must admit I was impressed, when we all had the time to sit down and figure out what had actually happened”.

Katsuki felt warmth spreading in his chest, but was too disoriented to understand why.

“I’m assuming you didn’t make it out in time because of Hatsume’s arrival?”, his teacher continued, raising an eyebrow.

Katsuki nodded.

“Had t’ go all th’ way back and grab’er. I knew we wouldn’ make it out in time t’gether. So I threw h’r first”.

Aizawa didn’t nod this time, just stared at him. Analyzing him again. Silently.

Katsuki felt uncomfortable, and his brain felt like it was about to shut down as soon as he blinked.

“She’s ok”, his teacher provided after a few tense moments, his face and tone of voice impassive, revealing none of what he was thinking. “She’s obviously very shaken up about everything that happened, and she dislodged her shoulder when you threw her out. It caused no permanent damage, though. She has already been cleared out of the hospital. She wanted to see you, but while investigations are still in course… We thought it better if you didn’t receive any visitors. For security reasons. You weren’t conscious enough to speak to her, anyway”.

That made Katsuki frown again, and something he hadn’t even thought about so far clicked in his mind.

“H’w long ‘ve I been out?”, he asked, heart rate speeding up. He felt nervous, out of a sudden. Nervous and worried. His senses became sharper.

“Bakugou”, Aizawa told him cautiously, a secret warning in his voice. He propped himself up on the chair, alert. “You need to calm down and relax”.

Katsuki swallowed dry. Had his brain not been so slow and sluggish, struggling to catch up with everything that he was becoming aware of, he would have realized that Aizawa had heard his heart monitor going crazy, even if Katsuki couldn’t. But Katsuki’s frantic brain decided that his teacher sensing his nervousness was shady, because he shouldn’t be able to read him so well.

“Wh’re’s Deku?”, he asked, finally realizing that Aizawa had not mentioned the boy at all after Katsuki’s question. He tried to move positions on the bed again, failing painfully and grimacing.

“He’s fine. Like I said, *everyone* is fine, no one but you got gravely injured”, his teacher provided. “So stop moving around”.

Katsuki let out a shaky, humorless laugh at this because yeah, was he supposed to feel relieved? When *he* had been the only loser who got fucked up in this mess? The only weakling who needed the hospital? The only idiot who didn’t make it out in time? For *fuck’s* sake.

“H’w long?”, he asked, breathing shakily. He ignored how his torso burned and how his words sounded dragged and blended together. “H’w long… ‘s it been?”

“Five days”, Aizawa said sharply, still looking stern but a bit more urgent. “Now *calm. Down”.*

And Katsuki tried, he really did, because he didn’t want to be fucking sedated and kept out for another five days, but it was *hard*. Because whatever happened to him after that explosion must have been bad enough to knock him out for almost a fucking week. And Aizawa said everyone was fine, so was Katsuki fucking insane? Because he was damn sure he had seen Deku’s bloodied face, and Kaminari’s, and both options were bad – either the two boys were actually hurt and Aizawa had lied to him, or they were totally ok and Katsuki had lost his fucking mind.

“Wha’ else?”, he urged, breathless, swallowing dry. The nasal cannula glued to his face was probably the only thing sending air into his lungs right now. “Wha’ happ’ned after th’explos’n?”

“You’re clearly in no state to talk about this right now”, Aizawa reprimanded, and he sounded – angry? Worried? Afraid? “We’ll discuss this when you’re better. You shouldn’t be under so much strain”.

“No”, Katsuki protested, hating how weak and raspy it came off. “I… I rem’mber Deku. Th’re was blood… And K’minari…”

Aizawa sighed heavily, serious.

“They’re *ok*. It wasn’t their blood, Bakugou”, he said simply – decisively.

Katsuki stared at him, eyes becoming glassier by the second. It seemed the drugs the nurse put into his IV were finally starting to have an effect, because his thoughts were becoming louder and more confusing, as opposed to his eyelids, which kept threatening to droop closed.

But he couldn’t fall asleep. Not yet.

“Wha’ happ’ned?”, he asked again, angry (even if it was weak). “Why w’s I out f’r three days?”

“Five”, Aizawa corrected, and Katsuki mentally kicked himself for the mistake.

His teacher sighed again, resigned – probably coming to terms with the fact that Katsuki wasn’t giving up and falling asleep like he should be.

“You didn’t make it out of the building before it exploded. You bashed your head pretty badly and the structure came down while you were still inside. You got… trapped beneath the rubble”, he clarified, and if Katsuki didn’t know him better, he would say he looked almost uncomfortable.

Aizawa glanced away for a moment before continuing.

“Other than breaking your arms and having what was described to me by your doctor as ‘possibly the worst concussion she’s ever seen’”, he added in a monotone, “you were also impaled and had several broken ribs, along with a punctured lung. Recovery Girl came over to help during your surgery, which was long yet successful, but she used up all your stamina on healing the most threatening injuries, which were the ones in your abdomen and head. The surgery took care of your lung just fine, but you need to take it easy for a while. Once you’re doing better and feeling stronger, she’ll come over again to finish healing your arms, which will probably make a full recovery, and that is why you need to *calm down*, take slow breaths, and *stop* using up all your energy on freaking out”.

Katsuki swallowed dry, realizing he was verging on hyperventilating – which explained the sudden pain on his chest and torso, evident even beneath the painkillers in his system. He tried to follow his teacher’s instructions and calm his breathing down, but it was hard after hearing that he had been so fucking close to dying because of an impalement injury – and that something as idiotic as a broken needle from an IV had the same chance of ending his life, just like that.

But Aizawa was right. He needed to calm down and save his energies, so that Recovery Girl could finish healing him and that he could leave that damn hospital. So he closed his eyes and tried to regulate his breathing, taking slow, deep breaths until the rhythm was back to normal.

Once his heart rate went back to a regular pace, his adrenaline rush came to an abrupt end and as a result he crashed, feeling lightheaded and doped. It was becoming harder and harder to stay awake, the painkillers added to his stress making him feel dizzy, sleepy, groggy, sluggish…

“Bakugou”, Aizawa called, his voice sounding echo-y and far away – even more so than it had been so far, which reminded Katsuki of his hearing again. “Are you still with me?”

Katsuki swallowed. He should have had more ice chips. He was starting to regret it, now.

“Ev’ryone’s f’ine?”, he asked, slurred. His eyes were rolling as he tried to keep them open, blinking several times in a row, with little success. The room was unfocused and starting to dim, becoming black and white. “No on’s hurt?”

“No”, Aizawa provided. And then, a bit more softly: “You can go to sleep, now. There’s nothing to worry about. I’m personally making sure of that”.

Katsuki wanted to complain, and to ask more, to know more, but he was too tired. So tired. Instead, for once, he obeyed.

Next time he woke up, he was a bit more coherent. At least coherent enough to realize that he was in a private room, the window to his right showed him it was night time, and Aizawa sensei looked like he hadn't slept in five days.

Yeah. He was still there, and he was awake.

Katsuki was also coherent enough to properly process the pain he was feeling. It was all over – probably an indicator that it was time for another dose of painkillers –, but more concentrated on his upper torso and his arms. It was a miracle he hadn't broken his legs, too, thinking about it, but he would take what he could get.

"Have you even slept?", Katsuki asked, his voice less slurry but more raspy. It still sounded weak, though.

Aizawa raised his tired eyes from the book that was supported on his lap, giving Katsuki yet another one of his analytical looks. The bags beneath the red-rimmed eyes were even more evident than usual.

"How are you feeling?", the teacher asked instead of replying, stoic.

"Sore, but fine", Katsuki lied. "You don' have to watch me all the time".

"Until the investigation is over, I do", Aizawa responded objectively. "It's either me or a police officer, and I think we both know what option is less likely to result in catastrophe".

"Katsuki clicked his tongue, looking away.

"In case you're thinking about a bratty comeback, allow me to remind you of what happened last time I left you here alone for five minutes", the man added, making Katsuki face him with a glare.

"I wasn't thinking straight", he defended himself.

"Hm", Aizawa hummed simply.

"An' I had just woken up alone in h're".

"Uh huh".

"I wanted to know what was goin' on".

“And the best way to do that was to try and get up by yourself, rather than try and press the buzzer right above your head?”

Katsuki narrowed his eyes.

“Didn’t know about the buzzer”, he protested. “Also, I don’ need help”.

Aizawa stared at him. Ok, correction – Aizawa *glared* at him.

Katsuki’s words seemed to have finally pushed the clearly sleep-deprived man to his limit.

“Bakugou”, he said, in a tone that made it very clear a scolding was in process. “Do me a favor and *don’t* put on this act. I nearly lost most of my students along with hundreds of civilians in an easily preventable terrorist attack that turned out almost deadly and *definitely* very expensive when it comes to civic construction. I’ve spent the past six days alternating between working the case with the police, preventing a school crisis, and watching over you so that you don’t get murdered in your sleep by any remaining villains. As a matter of fact, I *do* have more important priorities on my plate than sleeping, so don’t test my patience by pulling this now”.

Katsuki stared at him, a bit taken aback. Surely, Aizawa had been nothing if stern to him in the past, but he had never heard the man sound so… unhinged?

Instead of offering a *bratty comeback*, as he had been called out for, Katsuki simply stared up at the ceiling in silence, neither glaring nor scowling. Aizawa went back to reading his book in equal silence, and that was it for a little while.

“You should get some sleep”, Katsuki eventually broke the silence, voice still raspy. He didn’t look at his teacher, and his teacher didn’t look at him. “No use stayin’ here to fight a villain if you’re sleep depriv’d”.

Aizawa merely sighed, flipping a page of his book.

“I *have* been sleeping. When I can. Also, All Might and I have been taking turns watching over you”, he supplied.

Katsuki snorted.

“What’s he gon’ do? Spit blood on the villains?”, he commented sarcastically, but the joke tasted bitter on his tongue as soon as the words were out of his mouth. *Yeah, it’s your fault he can’t be a hero anymore, you fucking jerk. Go ahead and mock him for that, you piece of shit*.

Aizawa simply gave him a look before averting his attention back to his reading.

“There are also police officers standing guard by the door at all times, so rest assured you’re very protected”, he responded to Katsuki’s mockery, and then he fell silent again.

Katsuki decided his teacher wasn’t in the mood for much conversation – and he couldn’t say he was, either. Not that he *ever* was, as a matter of fact. And there was no point in staying awake staring at the ceiling when he could rest and regain his energy sooner, right? The

sooner he got his strength back, the sooner he could go back home and put all this shitshow behind him.

Since he had been assured that Deku and Kaminari and his other friends were ok, he could think about them later, when he wasn't caught up with stocking up the necessary stamina for Recovery Girl to fix his arms. He willingly decided to ignore his teacher's comment about being murdered in his sleep, because he really didn't have the energy to deal with that on that moment.

He closed his eyes, deciding to go back to sleep. Surprisingly, not thinking about the imminent threat he was under was easier than not thinking about Deku and his other friends. Because he had to be real – after everything they had gone through, during the past year and the museum day, it was only fair he wanted to see Deku standing there safe and sound with that dumb, cute face of his. Just to ease his mind. Just to calm his heart. And he really didn't want to admit that aloud, but he would if he had to, lest the nerd misunderstand him yet again.

Katsuki couldn't help but to think what had become of Deku – the last of him he remembered seeing was back at the auditorium, when Icy Hot dragged his paralyzed form away. He couldn't say this was a pleasant memory.

Not to mention Aizawa had said the building collapsed after the explosion. Deku couldn't have been too far away from the location when everything came down. Did he get hurt? If Katsuki was being watched for any possible villain attacks, was Deku too? And his other friends? And the other people in the museum? Was there even a police force large enough to protect so many people?

"Is Deku…", he ended up breaking the silence again, throat dry.

Aizawa looked at him, waiting for him to continue.

"Is he being… watched, too?"

A pause.

"Yes. Midoriya, Jirou, and Kaminari are all currently under protection as well, until we capture the villains who got away and determine whether there is a larger group behind the attack", Aizawa informed.

Katsuki swallowed dry.

"And… is he…", he hesitated.

Aizawa waited patiently.

Katsuki's jaw locked.

"… Ok?"

A pause.

“We already talked about this”.

“I know”, Katsuki replied with a bit of annoyance, offended. “But I’m stuck here, and he had a head injury last I saw him”.

Aizawa studied his face for a brief moment.

“He’s ok”, he supplied finally. “He had to stay in the hospital for a while, like Hatsume and Jirou, but has already been cleared out. Like the others, he and his mother are being secured until investigations come to an end”.

For some reason, that made relief course through Katsuki. But then, he frowned.

“Jirou…?”

Aizawa sighed.

“Her ears. Her jacks took a lot of damage, since she outstretched them beyond their limit in order to disarm the bomb. Think of it as distending a muscle”.

Katsuki grimaced in sympathy.

“But is she –“

“She’s fine, now”, Aizawa cut him off before he could start. “No permanent damage and a complete recovery. Like I’ve told you repeatedly – everyone is ok and you don’t have to worry. Focus on yourself”.

Katsuki snorted out a humorless laugh.

“People usually tell me the opposite of that”, he scowled. “But ok”.

Aizawa gave him a weird look, but didn’t respond. Instead, he went back to his book.

So ok. Deku was safe, Kaminari was safe, Jirou was safe… Katsuki would surely feel better if he could see them in person and attest that for himself, but he knew Aizawa sensei could be many things, except a sugar coater. If he said his friends were fine, then Katsuki would believe him.

He was ready to put some use into the relief he felt to know that his friends were ok despite the huge 11 story building that fell right at their faces, when a sudden thought appeared in his mind.

“Wha’ about my parents?”, he reopened his eyes, frowning at his teacher. His parents were surely worried about him, especially since they weren’t allowed to see him.

Aizawa lifted his eyes from his book again.

“They are fine”, he provided, a bit more patiently – probably because that was a reasonable concern (and Katsuki hadn’t made that question before). “They are also under protection, as

well as the others' families. A bit desperate that they don't get to be here with you. You mother did threaten several members of the staff until she was taken away".

Katsuki couldn't help but smirk at this.

"Sounds like the old hag all right".

Silence again.

Ok. So his parents were fine, too, along with his friends, which was reassuring. Inko and whoever else parented Jirou and Kaminari were also ok. All Katsuki had to worry about were his damn arms and his own damn recovery – Aizawa sensei was watching his back about the villains. But recovering which wouldn't be achievable if he didn't rest enough. He decided to put an actual effort into sleeping this time, now that he knew everything was fine. And that included not thinking about Deku.

The pain in his torso was starting to make him feel uncomfortable, but that was expectable, since he had been literally *impaled*, right? And Aizawa had also mentioned broken ribs and a punctured lung before. Overall, Katsuki was pretty fucked up, so being in pain wasn't exactly a surprise. He just needed to suck it up and he'd be better in no time.

Hey, Kacchan. You got that? Deku is in danger.

Katsuki frowned, eyes closed.

Why'm'I st'ck?

Nee' m'arms. An' m-my… h-h-han…ds… M'han's're… s-smash'd. M'hands're smash'd.

Katsuki swallowed dry again, the sudden memory making him feel cold all over. He couldn't remember when it had happened – the timeline was all messy inside his head, and he was using what his teacher had told him as basis.

"Are my hands gon' be ok?", Katsuki asked after a few minutes, raspy voice breaking the silence of the room again. He didn't open his eyes this time, but he could feel Aizawa's eyes glued on him.

"Yes", he replied after a beat. "You don't have to worry about your hands or your arms. Recovery Girl said you'll retain full mobility after you heal".

A bit more relief washed over Katsuki, but not enough to drown the pain, which was becoming more intense by the second.

"Wha' about my ears?", Katsuki swallowed, gritting his teeth to keep a whimper from escaping his throat. "I – I can hear you, bu' – it's – pretty muffled –", he grimaced.

A pause.

"We won't be able to assess the extent of the damage to your hearing until you're well enough to take a hearing test", Aizawa explained. "But we'll cross that bridge when we come

to it".

Ok, not so comforting. He knew his quirk was loud and potentially damaging to his hearing – he had always known that. But he hadn't expected to lose such a large percentage of his hearing at such an early age, and with such a small time window between the incidents. To be fair, he had shoved the warning he had received about the risks at the farthest back of his mind, because he wouldn't "tone down his explosions", as the doctor had suggested, just to preserve his hearing. It wasn't his hearing that would make him the greatest hero. It was his damn quirk.

He kind of wished he had listened to the doctor now, or at least done something about his warning. Not being able to hear properly was – well, it was –

He… Didn't know how to feel about it. He had freaked out when he first found out, after the incident in the sewers, but after that, he sort of… fixed it. And moved on. He had gotten his aid from Hatsume, and then the next version, and then the next, until the thing was good enough to not cause him pain or give him feedbacks. And that was it.

But thinking back to it… Deku had used that against him during their sparring, all those months ago. And back in the museum, there were several moments in which he didn't hear danger approaching – whereas Deku did. He was clearly bested.

Maybe he just needed to come to terms with the fact that his hearing wasn't the same anymore, and that no matter how talented Hatsume was, not even she could revert that.

But to think that he could have lost even *more* of his hearing… Yeah. Yeah, that was troubling, to say the least. And he was pretty sure he would have a full-on freak-out session about it, had it not been for the intense pain that was burning in his torso.

Soon enough, that was all he could focus on – not Deku, not his parents, not his arms and hands, not even his hearing, but the spreading pain on his stomach that allowed the echoes of his scraps of memory and his confusing, mixed-up thoughts to become even louder in his head.

Katsuki gritted his teeth even harder in an attempt to stop himself from crying out. There was sweat forming on his brow, he could feel it. In fact, even the pounding in his head was back with a vengeance, now. All he could do was lie there, try to breathe, and do his best to try and fall asleep. The annoying nurse would come soon. She would hook him up with the meds and he would be fine. He just needed to wait a little longer.

It was only when his already strained breathing started to hitch in his throat that he heard Aizawa sighing, the loud creaking of his plastic chair accompanying him when he stood up.

Katsuki only opened his eyes when he felt a hand squeezing his shoulder.

Aizawa was staring down at him with a tired, serious look, one comforting hand on his shoulder.

“Trouble kid”, he reprimanded, but his voice was uncharacteristically comprehensive. He shook his head slightly. “When will you learn?”

Katsuki frowned at him, jaw strained and brow sweating. He felt really nauseous because of the pain – so much so that he feared that, if opened his mouth to speak, he would end up spewing bile all over his teacher. Instead, he stayed silent, teeth grinding together.

“You’re one of the bravest students I’ve ever had, Bakugou”, Aizawa continued. His words were nice, so why did he sound like he was giving him a scolding? “Actually, you’re braver than some pros I know. You don’t have to try so hard”.

Katsuki’s frown deepened, but he found that he couldn’t say anything. All he did was lie there and tremble softly beneath Aizawa’s hold, the pain he was feeling increasing even further as he struggled to breathe past it.

“What I’m saying is”, he continued, sounding tired. “I’m your teacher. I’m here to help you and mold you into the competent pro I know you can become. I’m the last person in the world you should have to put an act to. More than anyone, I need to know what your limits are so I can know how far to push you”.

Before Katsuki’s addled brain could make sense of what he was being told, a blurry form appeared behind Aizawa. His eyes widened slightly, since his glassy eyes couldn’t really focus on the person, and his pained body’s reaction was to assume it was a villain, ready to attack them.

He gasped, flinching on the bed and trying to make a move. His limbs had become lead, however, and even if Katsuki could lift them, his hands and arms were enveloped by bandages and casts. The only thing the sudden movement of his body did was send a new wave of pain across his whole body, and he finally groaned.

Noticing his unease, Aizawa turned his head to see what had caused such a reaction in Katsuki.

“Did you call for me?”, a soft voice offered, and Katsuki stared in confusion. That sounded too nice for a villain.

“Yes”, he heard Aizawa provide. “He’s in a lot of pain. I think his last dose ran out”.

“Oh, poor thing”, the nurse – for who else could it be other than the annoying nurse? – said, and almost instantly something cold flowed into his arm. “I was about to come here to check on him. That should fix it. Did his doctor say something about that idea of shifting into new medication?”

“She said we should keep checking his progress”.

“All right. Call me again if anything changes, ok?”

“I will. Thank you”.

Katsuki swallowed dry again.

“Th’ doct’r came here?”, he asked, groggy. He couldn’t tell if the nurse was still there or not – last time, he could hear the door because he had been waiting for it to close, but now, his thoughts were way too loud and his pain was way too strong for him to focus.

“Yes. Yesterday”, Aizawa provided.

Katsuki frowned.

“I slep’ the whole day?”

“It’s morning, now. We decided it would be better not to wake you, when your doctor came by. You’re still recovering and she didn’t have any news. You’ve been asleep for a little over 12 hours, but that’s expectable and completely normal after the surgery and the trauma your body has endured”.

Katsuki’s heart skipped a beat out of fear and confusion.

“It’s not morn’n”.

“What was that?”

“It’s not morn’n. It’s dark”.

A pause.

“Your eyes are closed”.

Katsuki paused before blinking his eyes open again, embarrassed and kind of angry at the slip. Aizawa was a blurry form above him.

“B’t the window”, Katsuki insisted. “I saw it. ‘T was night”.

“Look again”, Aizawa said simply, taking a step to the side.

Katsuki squinted at the window to his right, noticing how clear and blue things seemed to be outside. Definitely not nighttime. But then, he could clearly remember seeing the window and seeing it was dark outside just a moment ago… Or had it been really just a moment? Had he fallen asleep in that meantime? If so, at what point of his conversation with Aizawa?

How many times had he fallen asleep without even realizing?

It was maddening, being stuck in this bed with no way to properly track time or what was happening. The worst part was how weak he felt. He depended on others to do everything, and he was clearly completely out of it.

Completely helpless.

He felt like he was losing his fucking mind.

Was this how Deku felt back when he woke up from the coma?

“What’s wrong?”, Aizawa placed another hand on his shoulder and squeezed, sensing his distress.

Katsuki was so out of it that he didn’t even think of pretending he was fine.

“I feel like ‘m losin’ it”, he grimaced. The drugs the nurse gave him were starting to make an effect – especially to his inhibition –, but he was still in quite a lot of pain. “Didn’ know I fell ‘sleep. Don’ even know wha’ day it is”.

“This is day six after your admission”, Aizawa provided promptly. “You first woke up yesterday morning, and then very quickly in the middle of the night. It’s 10 a.m. right now. Soon All Might will arrive to watch over you during the day, and then I’ll be back during the nighttime, which is usually when I do my rounds with you. You don’t have to worry about losing track of time; it’s normal that this should happen. Your body has gone through a lot –“

“B’t it’s been six days”, Katsuki protested, out of breath. “I should’n’ be this out of it”.

Aizawa sighed, a somber look flashing across his face for a split moment.

“Give yourself time to heal, kiddo”, he said, stoic. “You’re not doing yourself any favors by trying to jump back to your feet. You have to learn how crawl if you want to learn how to run”.

“B’t I shoul’ be better”, Katsuki insisted, sensing there was something wrong. “Rec’very Girl healed me. I should’n’ be like… this…”

Aizawa sighed heavily again.

“You’re underestimating the damage you took”, he said, serious. “Recovery Girl healed enough to make sure you would survive the surgery. You still have a long path in front of you until you’re back to 100%”.

Katsuki stared at him, confused.

“So just focus on resting and healing for now, and don’t stress over anything else”, he concluded, letting go of his shoulder. He sat back on his chair right beside Katsuki and grabbed his book again, without opening it. “Is the pain better?”

Katsuki thought for a moment, blinking sluggishly as he became groggier. Eventually, he nodded, eyelids struggling to stay open.

“Good”, Aizawa nodded back. “Then stop fighting sleep and rest. We can talk more when you’re feeling better”.

Katsuki wanted to protest, but his brain seemed to have created a will of his own. His eyes closed in spite of himself, and he would have immediately drifted off, had it not been for Aizawa’s voice calling his name from the dark.

“And Bakugou”.

It took Katsuki a few seconds to blink his eyes open again, finding his teacher's blurry, impassive face.

"Stop playing tough. I know you think you need to keep a reputation, but we nearly lost you back there. If you're in pain, just say it. No one here wants to watch you suffer because you're too proud to ask for help. Plus, the school is paying for your stay, so you'd better make some use of those painkillers they have here".

Katsuki was too weak and sleepy to reply, and fell asleep before he even could. But at least he was relieved that his parents wouldn't have to spend any money because of his weakness, even with the insurance, and especially because of the tough financial situation they had put themselves in.

When he woke up next, Aizawa was gone.

In his place was All Might.

Great.

"Bakugou *shonen*", All Might greeted him, sitting up straighter and leaning forwards on his seat. He sounded somewhat relieved to see Katsuki awake and definitely looked like he had been watching him sleep during this whole time, which he wouldn't doubt the man did.

Creep.

"All Might", he croaked, grimacing as he tried to move and the pain stopped him.

"Are you in pain?", All Might asked, attentive as always. "Do you need me to call the nurse?"

"No", Katsuki said.

"Aizawa told me –"

"It's just movin' that hurts", Katsuki blurted out, interrupting the man.

An awkward pause.

“I’ll be fine”, Katsuki resumed, a bit embarrassed by all that explicit attention. “I don’t need m’re right now. It’s just, I tried to move, and I can’t jus’ yet”, he admitted. He didn’t meet All Might’s eyes or even look at his general direction as he spoke.

Silence. He could feel All Might’s eyes glued to him like a hawk’s, which was annoying as fuck, but he still couldn’t bring himself to make eye contact.

Hate All Might Hate All Might Hate All Might Hate All Might Hate All Might. He didn’t get there in time to stop you from losing your hearing. He didn’t tell you or Inko that Deku was dying. He didn’t tell you that Deku didn’t remember his time as a ghost. He chose Deku over you. He forced you to take Deku’s quirk and make him miserable. He didn’t explain your side to Deku and let him keep hating you. He ended his hero career over you. Hate All Might Hate All Might Hate All Might Hate All Might –

Yeah. There was also that.

“Do you need help sitting up –“

“No”, Katsuki snapped, feeling unnaturally irritated by All Might’s presence and insistence to help.

Well, that and… All Might’s concern for him.

The fact that he *cared*. After everything. After the only reason Katsuki defeated those damn villains was because he… He *hated* him.

He sighed.

“All right”, All Might said simply, resigned and not even sounding offended. Katsuki closed his eyes and swallowed dry.

He could really use some fucking ice chips.

“How are you feeling, *shonen*?”, All Might asked, sounding genuinely interested in his answer, and *oh my fucking god would he stop doing that.*

“Sore”, Katsuki said sincerely, but a bit abruptly. “An’ like I was ’mpaled”.

That earned him a sympathetic smile.

“Well, that is accurate”, All Might said. “Your body has gone through a lot these past few days”.

“I know. Aiz’wa sensei said I was close to kickin’ the bucket”, he replied, finally bothering to look at All Might from the corner of his eyes, just to catch his reaction.

The man seemed taken aback for a moment, mouth opening and closing in surprise before he settled on a grim look.

“Yes, that is right”, he nodded solemnly. “It wasn’t easy, for any of us. Kaminari *shonen* has been particularly struggling to deal with what happened”.

And yeah, that definitely wasn’t the answer he had been expecting. What the fuck did *Kaminari* have to do with any of this?

“*What*?”, he asked, confused and, if he had to be honest, alarmed.

All Might stared at him, equally confused, until realization dawned on his face.

“Oh”, he said softly. “I see”.

For some reason, that only pissed Katsuki off more.

“See *what*?”, he asked, annoyed.

All Might sighed, standing up from the chair.

“I’ll go fetch you some ice chips”, he announced simply.

“All Might –“, Katsuki grunted, because *what a piece of evasive shit,* but the man was gone from his view before he could finish.

He couldn’t follow All Might with his gaze without moving and hurting himself, so he huffed, allowing his head to fall back on the pillows and his eyes to slip closed. He not-so-secretly hated the fact that he couldn’t do something as simple as seeing what someone else was doing in his own damn hospital room.

He also hated the fact that it was hard going back to a point where he didn’t hate All Might, since hating him had demanded so much effort and had saved the day. He hadn’t even considered that this would be a big deal up until now that he was actually forced to face the man. He realized, with delay, that he should have prepared himself mentally for this inevitable encounter sooner.

(In his defense, he had been extremely disoriented and pained every time he woke up so far, so a heart-to-heart with All Might hadn’t really been his top priority on the ‘things I should immediately worry about’ list.)

When he reopened his eyes and found the man standing in front of him with a cup of ice chips in one hand, Katsuki felt something acid burning in his chest.

All Might just stood there, looking a bit lost. Katsuki sighed and glared up at him.

“What?”, he asked upon All Might’s hesitance, a bit too aggressive.

“I – Well”, the man said, seeming embarrassed. “Should I feed them to you?”

Katsuki glared down at his casted, immobile arms, and then back up at All Might, tilting his head to the side.

“Do I look like I can take them myself?”, he asked, narrowing his eyes. Was All Might mocking him or something?

All Might shifted his weight from one leg to another.

“I didn’t know if you would be ok with that”, he admitted, and *fucking fine*.

He wasn’t mocking him. And maybe Katsuki didn’t *hate* him altogether, since he was apparently the only person left who still gave a damn about his honor.

“It’s not like I have another choice here”, Katsuki said, a little less venom in his tone – but some of it still there. He looked away in embarrassment. “Aizawa sensei had to do it, too”, he admitted, less angry.

All Might nodded, fishing one ice chip out of the cup with the little plastic catcher. He hesitated for a moment before offering it to Katsuki, who promptly took it in his mouth and chomped down on it with a loud crack.

All Might seemed startled at this, blinking a few times.

“I think you’re supposed to let them melt, shonen”.

“I just want to get this over with already so you can stop giving me that look and tell me what’s up with Kaminari”, Katsuki told him straightforwardly, taking another ice chip and chomping down on it again. This time, he didn’t break eye contact with All Might, glaring straight at him while he chewed.

All Might sighed, his shoulders slumping.

“I’m sorry about the look”, he said with sincerity.

Katsuki wished he hadn’t just apologized, because for some petty reason he wanted to keep using whatever reasons he could get to hate the guy. All this respect All Might was showing for him – valuing his will to choose, not overstepping his boundaries, *asking* about stuff before doing them – was making it *hard* to keep the hatred up. Why couldn’t he just be an asshole like everyone else and cut Katsuki some slack for once? He had almost died. That *had* to earn him some ‘I’m allowed to be angry’ points, right?

“I don’t really know how you expect me to act around you”, All Might concluded, pensive, and ok, *what*.

Katsuki blinked, focusing back on the conversation.

“What are you talking about?”, he frowned. All Might offered him another ice chip instead of replying.

Katsuki eyed him with suspicion for a moment before taking it hesitantly. He was still pretty fucking thirsty after all. But he didn’t chomp on it this time. Instead, he merely cracked it in half between his teeth and allowed the two pieces to melt in his mouth.

All Might looked away, tired.

“I know you value your pride greatly, shonen”, he shrugged. “And I know it must be hard for you to be in this situation, where you depend on others to recover”.

Katsuki narrowed his eyes.

(Really, *fuck* All Might for being the only person so far who had displayed such a concern. Katsuki really didn’t know how to feel about it, and he hated it.)

“But what you did was incredibly brave and heroic, and you saved a lot of lives. So you should know none of us think any less of you for needing help right now, and in fact it is an honor to us to be able to help you after the good you did”, he added, sincere. Looking into his sunken eyes, Katsuki found only honesty. “I speak from personal experience. In moments like this, when you’re hurt but feel like you need to keep on smiling and wearing a strong façade, so that the world doesn’t see that you, too, can bleed… Those are the moments when you can’t turn down the help from those who care about you. You need to let your pain be seen by those you can trust, so that you can keep being strong for those who need to trust you”.

Katsuki’s face scrunched up in an ugly expression and he realized, with an accompanying sense of shame and mortification, that the blurriness in his vision had been caused by tears. Five minutes of interaction with All Might had caused him to feel more emotions that all his previous conversations with Aizawa sensei. Maybe it was because Aizawa wasn’t an overly comprehensive dickhead who made effortless supportive speeches that unknowingly hit root aspects of his personality, all while he was stuck to a *fucking hospital bed,* Jesus fucking Christ.

Ok, he definitely couldn’t do this right now. Not without ending up crying like a goddamn baby in front of All Might, of all people, which he definitely didn’t want – no matter how touching his little speech had been. So he sucked it up, blinked his tears back into his damn eyeballs and glared up at All Might, deciding to deflect the subject before those painkillers made him lose his remaining honor.

“Why did you say Kaminari is struggling?”, he asked, not bothering to respond to All Might’s reassuring words.

The man’s shoulders sagged again as he fed another ice chip to Katsuki, who didn’t break eye contact this time.

“I wrongly assumed Aizawa had told you about what happened, since he told you about how we nearly… Lost you. Now, I’m not so sure if this is a subject that we should discuss for the time being”.

“Oh, I think it is”, Katsuki told him seriously. “I wanna know wha’ happened”.

All Might met his eyes, hesitating for a second.

“What has he told you, exactly?”

“Tha’ the building collaps’d on me and tha’ I was impaled. And tha’ Recovery Girl healed what she could to keep m’ from dying during the surgery”.

All Might studied his face, a grimace painting his lips.

“Nothing else?”, he asked, careful.

Katsuki scoffed.

“What *else* is there?”, he questioned.

All Might sighed again.

“Do you want any more ice chips?”, he asked, deflective.

“No. Just the truth”, Katsuki said, staring at him with intensity.

All Might nodded, lowering his head pensively before walking away to discard the rest of the ice chips. When he returned, he went all the way around Katsuki’s hospital bed to sit back on the plastic visitor chair.

Katsuki stared at him. All Might stared at the floor for a while before meeting his eyes.

“When we got to you”, he started, somber. “You were in a really bad shape. In fact, you went through cardiac arrest while we were moving you out of the rubble. It was Kaminari *shonen* who managed to bring you back, using his quirk”.

Flashes of Kaminari’s face, half-covered in blood and looking desperate, staring down at him and yelling something he couldn’t hear –

“The experience was, obviously, very…”, All Might continued. “*Intense*. And traumatizing. Most of all, he is really concerned about you”.

Katsuki took a deep breath. Yeah, he knew how Kaminari must be feeling. This was a horrible thing to witness and to remember, as Katsuki could tell first hand. It wasn’t something someone could walk away from easily, especially when it happened to someone close.

To a friend.

“Can’t he come here and see I’m fine or something?”, Katsuki asked, already knowing the answer.

“Not until the investigation is concluded”, All Might provided, and Katsuki rolled his eyes, having guessed correctly. “But we are very close to an end, so you should be able to receive visitors soon”.

Katsuki scoffed.

“Yeah. Looking forward to that”, he grumbled. Deep down, he really *was* looking forward to that, but he wasn’t about to let All Might know about that, or about *whose* visit he was eager for.

All Might gave him a tiny smile accompanied of yet another sight.

“I imagine it will be a bit tiring to you. But believe me, *shonen*. There are a *lot* of people who are looking forward to seeing you awake. We were all worried about you”.

Katsuki stared at All Might, trying to read his face.

All Might stared back at him, doing the same.

A few moments of awkward silence. Time to finally address the elephant in the room.

“And how’s Deku faring up?”

The hint of a tiny smile appeared on All Might’s lip, but Katsuki chose to ignore it. If he picked up a fight with All Might right now, it would be injury-ailed person 1 versus injury-ailed person 2.

“I mean, last I rem’mber he was fucked up b’cause a villain knocked him in the head, and Icy Hot was draggin’ him away b’cause he was still paralyzed by that stupid quirk. Did he fin’lly find some common sense and let th’ doctors tend to him or did he insist he was ok even though his brains were bash’d in?”

All Might stared at him, lips slightly parted as if he was in shock.

Katsuki frowned at the reaction.

“What?”, he demanded, confused.

“N-Nothing, shonen”, All Might said, and ok, that was clearly a lie.

Katsuki narrowed his eyes.

“Tell me”, he demanded. All Might offered him a fake smile.

“It’s nothing. Midoriya *shonen* is doing much better. Recovery Girl was too focused on your surgery to help anyone else, but his… head injury was superficial. He has been discharged already, but he is, of course, worried sick about you”, he deflected, probably thinking Katsuki wouldn’t notice. “While the investigation is still in progress, UA suspended class 1-A’s lessons. The students are staying home with their families, Midoriya *shonen* included. They will all be provided with the necessary mental health follow up should they request it, since it was a very unexpected, traumatic event”.

Katsuki scoffed, disdainful.

All Might gave him a curious look.

“You disagree?”, he asked, curious.

Katsuki rolled his eyes, feeling a bit more sober.

“We’re attacked by villains every other week”, he said, blunt. “Hell, I was literally *kidnapped* by the League of Villains, who wanted to brainwash me into becoming one of them, and the school didn’t offer me or anyone else involved *shit*”.

All Might nodded, serious.

“I know”, he said. “That is why we are doing it now”.

Katsuki stared at him, not sure how to react.

All Might sighed, leaning forwards on his seat again.

“It’s only through our mistakes that we can learn”, he said, serious. “And, I must admit, it took us a lot of mistakes to finally get it right”.

“Get what right?”, Katsuki frowned.

“That being a hero doesn’t mean being unbreakable”, he responded simply, leaning back against the chair’s rest. “Though I do think my dramatic retirement was what it finally took to make them realize that”.

Katsuki gave him an amused huff of breath, face impassive.

“But after that, and after your own incident in the sewer, some of the teachers finally got into the council’s head that we are dealing with students, not war machines like some would think”, All Might continued. “And that mental health was an important factor when raising a healthy, successful hero”.

Katsuki continued to stare at him, quiet.

All Might lowered his head.

“Our job, it is…”, he took a deep breath. “It’s a tough job. We lose people, and we deal daily with death, and pain, and suffering… We can’t always save everyone that we wish we could save”, he shook his head. Katsuki had a feeling All Might was talking about something very personal, but he couldn’t really tell what. The man kept his eyes downcast. “Sometimes, it can become too much. And if we’re not careful, the guilt will swallow us up. The paranoia. The fear. The worry. Those are all very important for our self-preservation, but only when they are in our control. And I believe you would agree with me that therapy is a nice way to get it under control, wouldn’t you?”

Yeah. Especially if I need to trick myself into channeling my pent-up anger issues to hate you so I can defeat a bunch of D-listers who want to eradicate you from history.

Katsuki found himself unable to keep looking at All Might. The man continued anyway.

“But it was about time we provided this sort of service for the students, and not just the ones in the hero course. Everyone agreed so. I do believe our society spent too long believing that if a hero in training couldn’t handle the trauma, then they weren’t fit to be a pro hero. But my opinion is the opposite”, he shrugged.

Katsuki looked at him from the corners of his eyes.

“Sometimes, we think that we’re dealing well with the trauma. We bury it deep within our hearts, we ignore it, we don’t think about it. And we think it’s handled. Because we’re strong, we can just hide it and move on. But then, something comes back, because it always comes back, and the trauma resurfaces. And it can happen in a way that makes us do something we’ll regret immensely. Something that could even destroy us”.

Katsuki narrowed his eyes, tilting his head to properly look at All Might.

“I have a feeling you’re just talking about yourself”, he commented.

All Might chuckled, amused.

“Yes. Yes, I am”, he nodded, looking at Katsuki. “But I’m also talking about you. And Midoriya *shonen*. And Kaminari *shonen*. And all of your colleagues who went through something terrible. None of you should deal with that on your own, especially in your age”, he admitted. “So yes, we have agreed that everyone who wants it will have access to therapy. It wasn’t the easiest of discussions, but it’s settled now. And, in a way, it’s all thanks to you”.

Katsuki scoffed.

“Why, because I was the first loser who needed it?”

All Might stared at him.

“Because you were the first to show them that not only it worked, but it also improved your potential”.

Katsuki looked away, feeling angry. He couldn’t really tell why, but he did.

He didn’t need the damn therapy to be a great hero. All he ever needed was his quirk, and his own fucking ability. His will, and his greatness, and his hard work. *That* was what would take him to the top of the charts. Not a shitty heart-to-heart with Doctor Matsuo.

And yet… Katsuki couldn’t help but to wonder if he would have been able to turn the villain’s game around had he not been in control of his emotions. Because sure, before therapy and before the sewers and before ghost Deku, his emotions had been: 1. All over the place, and 2. Anger: that’s it.

Now, he had *more* of his emotions all over the place and he still felt pretty much angry, but he was better at managing it. He still had his freak outs every now and then, but he was also better at acknowledging what had caused them and how to fix them. So no, he didn’t think he would have been able to defeat the *damn* villains if he hadn’t been in such a precise control

of his own emotions, but he wasn't about to tell All Might that, especially because of *how* he had defeated the villains.

Instead, he went back to staring at the ceiling, a serious, grumpy look on his face. All Might seemed to have sensed his discomfort, because he was soon leaning forwards on his seat again to take a better look at Katsuki.

"Are you… in pain?", he asked, concerned and probably assuming that was the reason behind Katsuki's discomfort.

Katsuki glared at him. All Might didn't falter.

"I've had a nasty injury on my side for years now, *shonen*", All Might added simply. "If you're in pain, you can say it".

Katsuki sniffed, hating that he was right. But he wasn't in pain – not too much, at least. He could still feel the meds running through him and dulling the most of it. In fact, he was still tired enough to go right back to sleep if he wanted. He wasn't slurring, which was good, but he was secretly exhausted.

"It's manageable", he said, not meeting All Might's eyes.

A pause.

"I see", All Might hummed comprehensively.

"It *is*", Katsuki scoffed.

From the way his thoughts were starting to disperse, Katsuki knew he didn't have too long before he succumbed to unconsciousness again, and when he woke up fuck knew how long later, it probably wouldn't be All Might by his side. If anything, this was the first time in two days he had managed to see the guy.

And no matter how angry he still felt at the man, no matter how irritated and annoyed he was by his presence, Katsuki knew he didn't really hate All Might. Not for real. Not in any way that counted. So there was still something he needed to set right, which probably explained why he had been so snappy and aggravated when he woke up to see the man by his bedside.

He didn't want to do it like this, not while he was still weak and medicated on a damn hospital bed. Like he had realized before, he wanted to have the chance to prepare better for such a conversation.

But if he avoided the subject right now, he would probably never find a window to approach it ever again. He could always use the medication part on his favor and justify the sappiness that was about to ensue, but he wasn't a coward. If he was going to do this, then he was going to own it. Just like he was owning all the pathetic stuff he had been doing ever since he woke up.

Katsuki turned his head to face All Might.

“Did they tell you how I did it?”

All Might tilted his head.

“Hm?”

“How I defeated the villains. Turned their plan around”.

All Might blinked, comprehension dawning on his face.

“No”, he shook his head. “No one really knew how precisely you did that. But we have a vague idea”, he shrugged.

There was nothing but comprehension in his face and in his voice, and fuck if Katsuki didn’t loathe it.

He wished All Might was angry. He wished All Might would resent him for resenting him, hate him for hating him. He wished All Might would look at him with something other than sympathy and care and *understanding.*

Fuck.

“I hated you”, Katsuki admitted, swallowing, staring up at the ceiling like a coward. “They grabbed all those people who loved you so much and converted their love into hatred. So instead of loving you like I did all my life, I decided to hate you. I decided to hate you so much that it would be enough to smother all those people’s love, and that was what destroyed their plan. They never saw it coming”.

He couldn’t see All Might’s reaction, since he was purposefully avoiding to look at him. The silence stretched on for a little while.

“And what did you hate me for?”, All Might asked, and *for fuck’s sake*, why did he sound so comprehensive right after Katsuki told him that he hated him to his *face*?! Like this was a goddamn thought exercise or something?!

He scoffed, shaking his aching head and never looking at All Might.

“Tch. *Everything*. For choosing Deku instead of me. For giving him your quirk and dragging him into this path. For hiding stuff from his mom. For hiding stuff from me, even after he woke up. For…”, he hesitated.

And then he sighed heavily, closing his eyes.

“For not standing up for me when he was angry”.

All Might was very quiet.

“But what I wanted to say”, Katsuki swallowed again, reopening his eyes and continuing to stare at the ceiling. “Is that I understand why you did all those things. Even if I don’t agree

with all of them. And…" he bit the inside of his cheek. "I just needed to stop them. So I used what I had. They wanted to make the entire world hate you".

A pause.

"I know".

Katsuki frowned, and finally turned his head to look at him.

All Might was gazing at him patiently.

"That is why I told you your potential was improved by therapy", All Might revealed. "Your experience with it helped you do what none of the heroes in training there could. And the mastery you displayed over your own emotions in such a situation of crisis only shows that you really will be remarkable one day".

Katsuki stared at him for a few more moments, a look of incredulity in his face, before he scoffed in amusement.

"So you *knew* how I did it", he said in an accusatory tone.

"I figured, from everyone's testimony on what had happened, that this would have been the only way", All Might shrugged simply. "No one there bore the same capacity for passionate rage as you did".

Katsuki scoffed again, this time in disdain and a bit of hurt. *You're more than just your anger,* Doctor Matsuo's voice resonated in his head, but while it made him feel a bit better, it didn't solve his current problem.

"And you're no'… p'ssed at me?", he asked, his speech starting to drag as his exhaustion became harder and harder.

All Might booming, trademark laughter resonated in the room, startling him from his sleepiness for a moment.

"Bakugou *shonen*!", he exclaimed, amused. "Why on *earth* would I be mad at you after you saved hundreds of lives and stopped the entire world from being brainwashed into despising me?", he asked, genuinely interested.

Katsuki squinted in confusion, relaxing against the pillows. It took him a moment to reply.

"I only p'lled it off bec'se I was angry at you", he explained, slurring. His vision was starting to become a bit blurry, his eyes struggling to remain open.

All Might chuckled again, shaking his head slightly as he leaned forwards on his seat.

"And you were rightfully so, my boy. I wronged you, and Mrs. Midoriya, and so many others, so many times. I can only hope you will make a full recovery so I can make up to you for all that", he told him sincerely, tapping Katsuki's shoulder in a comforting manner.

Katsuki merely stared up at All Might in confusion. His brain was too sluggish to really comprehend what was happening right now. So, apparently All Might didn't hate his guts forever or even as much as despised him for what he had done. And apparently, he would have to deal with all that later, when he wasn't taking a trip down painkiller land.

"Well, j'st wanned to say I don' actually hate you", he slurred finally, eyes drooping closed. He was out in less than a minute, his breathing evening out and becoming less strained once he fell asleep.

"I know, my boy", All Might petted his bandaged head gently. "I know".

He opened his eyes, finding the room immersed in a blue darkness.

The only source of light came from a dim lamp somewhere to his left, and after his eyes adjusted to the dark, he spotted Aizawa sitting on the chair by his bedside, arms crossed above his chest and head bowed down as he napped. Apart from his stiff arms, he was sat slack on his seat. The uncomfortable position he was in would probably result in a backache when he woke up.

Tch. Like hell he was keeping watch sleeping like that.

Katsuki tried to guess what time it was, but it was impossible to tell. The window directly behind his teacher was dark, so he assumed it was far into the night, since Aizawa said he took the night rounds.

Katsuki was about to close his eyes again and go back to sleep, since he needed all the rest he could get, when a noise caught his attention.

He snapped his head to the side, in spite of the pain, his crimson eyes searching for the source of the sound in the darkness. All he saw was the door, closed, and the empty hallway outside through the glass wall. The faintest light was entering the room through it, but not enough for Katsuki to see if there was someone else in there.

There didn't seem to be anyone outside, which was odd, since he had been told there would always be police standing guard there. But then, he had never actually *seen* the police guards, not even back when he was more sober and swimming in daylight.

Maybe he had just imagined things. Maybe the noise he had heard had just been one of the very real police guards grabbing something to eat, or swapping rounds. Either way, he shouldn't worry. He was as safe as he could be, in a hospital with Aizawa sensei watching his back.

He turned his head back so that he could try to catch some more sleep, and then he spotted it.

There was someone standing by his bed.

Katsuki jolted into a sitting position, the sudden movement disrupting his healing impalement injury. The sharp pain it caused him and the sudden shock made him suck in a loud gasp, which resulted in Aizawa's eyes snapping open almost immediately.

Despite the violent pain he was feeling from having moved so abruptly, Katsuki leaned back on the bed, raising his (aching) casted arms towards the man standing beside his teacher in the dark. But before he could even think about igniting an explosion (he couldn't even begin to imagine the kind of pain that would cause) or before Aizawa could immobilize the invader, the man…

Smiled?

And, with ice spreading through his veins and a very painful drop of his stomach, Katsuki recognized him. He could finally see the burn marks on his face and all the way down his neck and arms, the missing hair from half of his head, the arrogant, holier-than-thou air that tinged the evil smirk on his lips.

It was the villain from the museum. The one who inverted people's emotions.

The one who turned his hatred for All Might into love. The one who set the fucking *bombs*.

"You should have minded your own business", he said simply, almost cheerfully.

And before Katsuki could begin to comprehend how the hell that son of a bitch had survived the explosion, Aizawa was walking past the villain as if he was nothing and jumping at Katsuki, hands wrapping around his neck and squeezing.

Katsuki flailed his arms and legs madly despite the sharp pain in his abdomen. It did nothing to stop Aizawa's tight grip around his throat. The sound of his heart monitor going off like crazy was an accurate picture of his growing panic. His teacher was fucking strangling him, after all.

He tried to make his hands pop in an attempt to at least free himself, but it was for nothing – no explosion was ignited from his palms. And he had a lot on his mind at that moment to even think about the possibility that his quirk might have been impaired somehow, but a twinge of fear about that still made his heart beat even faster.

"S-Sen… sei…", he tried to croak out, his casted arms slapping at his teacher's chest since he couldn't use his quirk. But his voice was just a dull whisper of pain and breathlessness. His

lungs were burning and begging for air, but no matter how hard he tried to inhale, nothing made it into them.

Fuck, that was one hell of a sadistic way of killing him. Making him feel safe and protected by Aizawa's presence, and then having him, who was one of the few people that he still trusted, murder him in cold blood. *In his sleep,* like the teacher had been trying to prevent.

Katsuki's eyes were wide as saucers as he opened and closed his mouth, never ceasing his attempts to break free. But no matter how much he kicked and wriggled around, Aizawa's hands around his neck were relentless, squeezing tightly and mercilessly.

Then, his binding cloths wrapped Katsuki's arms and legs to keep him from struggling. So he could choke him and kill him faster.

The worst part was that he looked normal. There wasn't an ounce of rage in his face, an ounce of indifference. Nothing that indicated he was being mind-controlled, nothing that indicated his feelings were all over the place. Only a meticulous spark of determination, as if he just really wanted to get this done with so he could go on about his life.

As if Katsuki would let him.

Despite the binding cloths holding his limbs in place, he kept struggling. And he ignored the villain's mocking laughter coming from beside him – well, he couldn't really hear it anyway, not with the ringing in his ears. His vision was becoming blurry and black spots were dancing in front of his eyes, but he could still see Aizawa's face – impassive, focused, and determined.

"S… S-Sen… s…", he tried again, weaker this time. His arms were starting to feel heavy and numb. So were his legs. He could barely even feel the hurtful wound on his side anymore. But he had to keep fighting. He had to keep trying to push him away.

He couldn't give up. He still needed to give Deku his quirk back – almost dying in that rubble had been close enough of a call. He still had his whole career in front of him. He still had his whole *life* to live.

"Stop struggling, Bakugou", Aizawa told him in his usual monotone, making it sound like he was scolding his student for being too loud during a lecture. He definitely didn't sound like he was strangling an injured teen to death – *or* like he was having trouble doing it, for that matter. "I'm doing everyone a favor", he added pensively.

Katsuki had it in himself to frown at this, never ceasing to try and flail around, despite the cloths binding him and the fact that he barely had any strength in him to keep moving.

"It seems you chose a proper hero name for yourself, explosion boy", the villain teased him, crouching beside him on the bed while Aizawa continued to strangle him. "After all… *King Explosion Murder* describes what you did back in that museum pretty well".

No, Katsuki wanted to say. *I didn't plant that bomb. Aizawa sensei told me no one else was hurt. He said I was the only one gravely injured. This guy is lying. Of course he is lying, he's*

a filthy villain who's angry I ruined his shitty plan and now he's making my fucking teacher kill me in a fucking hospital bed. God, this is so humiliating.

His struggles were becoming weaker and weaker and weaker by the second. His heart was beating so fast he was sure the heart monitor must have broken by now – not that he could hear it anymore. Everything was eerily silent. He wondered if that was why no nurse or doctor had come to check on him yet… Or had the villain murdered them? Where were the police guards? Where was everyone?

He was alone. He was doomed, and all alone. He couldn't trust anyone anymore – not even his own body.

He could feel consciousness escaping him, and he couldn't die like this. That was a pathetic way to die. He couldn't even defend himself, for god's sake. He couldn't die like this, but he couldn't fight back, and he couldn't free himself, and he couldn't feel his arms, or his face, and the pressure inside his head made it feel like his skull was about to blow up like a balloon, and he couldn't breathe, everything was spinning and blurring and his vision was starting to fade for good…

Katsuki woke up under tremendous pain.

He blinked his eyes open, wide as saucers. When he tried to swallow past the agony, he felt bile threatening to rise up his throat. He squeezed his eyes shut in his effort to keep it down, but it hurt – the pain was so intense it was making him dizzy. He tried to grab the bedsheets for comfort, but a bolt of pain shot up his arms – and then he remembered they were enveloped in casts.

He gasped, trying to focus on anything that wasn't the intense fire burning him from inside out. Trying to catch his breath. Trying to understand what was happening.

"Bakugou", there was a familiar voice calling him, but he flinched at the sound and at the hand that accompanied it.

"S-Stay away", he barked out, breathless, his voice coming out weak and raspy. He raised his casted arms in defense, ready to use his quirk and attack, but then he remembered that his quirk hadn't worked when he tried to use it. His eyes widened further.

“You were having a nightmare”, Aizawa explained to him, not touching him per his warning but staying nearby, hands hovering above his student as if he was trying to calm a feral animal. “You need to calm down and breathe properly, or you’ll disrupt your injury”, he explained patiently, taking a step closer and touching Katsuki’s shoulder, attempting to push him down in to a lying position.

“I said stay the fuck *away*!”, Katsuki screamed, but it was so, so off – nothing like his usual booming shouts or cranky orders. His voice had cracked. It sounded desperate, and fearful, and he hated that he had emitted such a sound in the first place. He sounded, more than ever, like the teenager he was.

He tried to crawl away from his teacher, eyes wide and panicked, heart monitor screaming desperately above him – but much more muffled than it had been in his dream.

The door burst open, and following it a painful flash of white light hit Katsuki’s eyes, and suddenly there were people entering the place – unknown people, alien people, people who could very well be villains trying to murder him or his teacher or make his teacher murder him or murder him *and then* his teacher. Whoever these people were, Katsuki didn’t feel safe with them. He didn’t feel safe with anyone.

“Stay back!”, Aizawa commanded, outstretching a hand towards the person before they could approach the bed.

“Sir, the patient –“, they tried to argue, continuing to walk into the room.

“I *know*, but he was in a traumatic event recently and you’re startling him. Let me calm him down, first”, he explained in a rush, but the authority never left his tone.

“Sir –“

“Stay *back*”, Aizawa basically growled, his body shielding Katsuki’s heavy-breathing form.

The person’s eyes darted from the panicking Katsuki to his teacher standing protectively in front of him.

“He’s bleeding”, they pointed out meekly, but stayed where they were. Aizawa snapped his head to look at Katsuki, who was half-sitting, half-lying on the bed, panting widely as if he had just run a marathon, and looking like he was about to pass out.

His torso was a gruesome sight of blood, from his chest down to his thighs, the once blue hospital gown glued sickly to his skin. His face, now enlightened by the bright lamp in the ceiling, was ashen, and sweat was visible on his forehead. With each breath he took, his defensive posture sagged more, to the point he was basically heaving in his attempt to suck in loud breaths.

Aizawa was immediately by his side, and even if the boy tried to push him away with his casted hands, he was too weak to do so. The teacher crossed the remaining distance between them before Katsuki could collapse off the bed and supported his increasingly sinking

weight, and Katsuki could do nothing but allow himself to be supported as he struggled to breathe.

Katsuki's eyes were drooping as the nurse – because it must have been a nurse, right? – finally approached him, Aizawa taking his head between his hands. Katsuki tried to shrug away again, but couldn't, and then his teacher finally realized how absolutely hot the boy's skin felt. He was burning up with fever.

He snapped his head towards the nurse, who had been followed in by other two. She was trying to inspect Katsuki's injury amidst all the blood.

"He's –"

"Burning up, we know", she said shortly, frowning in concentration.

Katsuki shivered in Aizawa's hold, still trying to pull away but unable to do so. Aizawa focused his attention on his student again, respecting his request that he'd stay away by settling him back into bed in a manner that he wouldn't risk falling off. He let go, but Katsuki remained tense.

"Wh'r's… v'llain…", Katsuki tried to say, but his voice was wet and breathless. Aizawa frowned.

"There's no villain", he explained patiently. "You were having a fever dream".

Katsuki simply breathed wetly, shivering again, glassy eyes looking around the room without focusing on anything in particular.

"Di' he mean it?", he choked out. Aizawa frowned.

"Mean what?"

Katsuki gasped and grimaced, eyes squeezed shut in pain. He threw his head back as the nurse continued to examine his injury.

"Di' – Did I kill s'meone?", Katsuki choked out, face scrunched up. Aizawa blinked in shock at him.

"Bakugou, you didn't kill anyone", he reassured him, worried at his student's unusual uncertainty.

Katsuki stared at his teacher's face without quite seeing him, seeming uncharacteristically lost.

"Wha' about my quirk?", he swallowed, weak.

"What about it?", Aizawa asked, doing his best to keep the concern from his face.

"Wha' happened to it?", Katsuki grimaced again, twisting and sweating on the bed. "Where'd it go? Where'd it go? Wha' happened to it?"

Aizawa's frown deepened.

"Nothing", he said, taken aback. "Nothing happened to it. It's there".

"No", Katsuki shook his head. "No, no, no. Why'd he le' you go?"

Aizawa blinked again, trying to make sense of Katsuki's words.

"From where?"

"Th' contr'l", Katsuki's eyes slipped shut, suddenly too tired to keep that up. "You st'pped str'nglin' me. Di' he let you go?"

Aizawa stared at him in shock.

"You dreamt I was *strangling* you?", he asked, eyes wide.

But Katsuki didn't respond. His head had fallen back against the askew pillows, mouth open and slack, lolling limply to the side. He looked young – too young.

And then, Aizawa found himself stepping away from the bed as one of the nurses yelled something about an operation room, and before he could ask them about what was happening or where they were taking his student, Katsuki was rushed out of the room.

When he woke up, he couldn't really feel anything.

Actually, he felt like he was floating.

Like a petal on a stream –

He decided he didn't like it.

"Stop tha' an' just pu' me on the ground", he told no one in particular, authoritative.

"Oh, I think he's awake".

There were faint footsteps all around him, he couldn't really tell. Left or right, it didn't really matter. He didn't know where it was coming from. He wasn't even sure he had heard anything…

“Hey, son. How are you feeling?”

Huh. Weird.

“Don’ call me son”, he retorted, petty.

A pause.

“Why not?”

“’Cause ya ain’ my dad”.

“Really?”

“M’ dad’s not s’me wimpy shit los’r who calls p’ple son. My dad’s my… dad”.

“All right. But how do you know I’m not your dad?”

“C’se you’re *not*”.

“Hm. Why don’t you try opening your eyes and seeing it for yourself?”

Katsuki frowned. What the hell was this fucker talking about? But hey, maybe his eyes *were* closed because everything was very dark and black and he couldn’t really see. So he tried. How does one open their eyes again? He thought there was some sort of reverse blinking involved, but he couldn’t really remember…

It took him a while to get it right. Once he did, everything was too bright and white and he hated it, so he closed his eyes again with a groan.

“Come on”, the person talking to him urged. “Make a little effort”.

“Shu’ up”, Katsuki groaned, pissed off. “Don’ tell me wha’ to do”.

“Well, he seems to be back to normal”, another voice said from the distance. Katsuki frowned.

He tried the reverse blinking again, and this time he managed to keep one of his eyes open despite the uncomfortably bright light. After adjusting his sight for a few moments, he finally focused on the face looming above him.

Shit. It *was* his dad.

“Th’ hell you’re doin’ here?”, Katsuki squinted, confused and dizzy. What day was it? What happened? Where were Aizawa and All Might?

“Nice to see you too, brat”, Mitsuki stepped next to Masaru, arms crossed above her chest. Even though she sounded like a cranky old hag as usual, there was something weird about her face – something Katsuki couldn’t quite place. “Are you done giving your old woman grey hairs or do you have some more shit to pull off?”

“Mitsuki…”, Masaru reproached, sounding somber.

“No, really, I want to know”, she said, sounding... Resentful? “Because I’d rather be prepared next time. Grey hair looks like *shit* on me, so if he has any more of this *crap*, I want to know so I can start saving money for my hair dye”.

Katsuki’s eyes darted between his parents’ faces, trying to make sense of what was happening.

“What she’s trying to say”, Masaru told him, patient as ever. “Is that we were really worried about you”.

“Worried?”, Mitsuki exclaimed, and Katsuki tried to make sense of the red marks around her eyes, and of its puffiness, and of the disheveled way her clothes and hair were looking. She never looked like this. She was always tidy and composed, never… *this*. It kind of freaked him out. “Oh, Masaru, you really want to talk about *worried*?”, she laughed humorlessly, her tone of voice raising slightly with each word.

Masaru sighed and lowered his head, preparing himself for what was coming.

“Honey, we talked about this. We’re in a hospital –“

“I was losing my *goddamn mind,* Katsuki, Jesus, can you stop putting us through this shit?”, she downright screamed despite her husband’s warning. “I thought you were dead, kid! *Dead*! It was all over the news, and then they wouldn’t let us stay with you for security reasons or whatever the hell, and then you nearly killed yourself all over again and needed another surgery and I swear to god, Katsuki Bakugou, if you ever make me sit on a shitty hospital chair and watch over my dying son without knowing if he’ll pull through, I’ll make sure you live *just* so I can kill you myself!”

“Honey…”

Katsuki continued to blink up at his mom and his dad, trying to catch up with the words. Dead…? Security reasons…? Another surgery…?

“Wha’ happ’n’d? I don’ rememb’r”, he frowned instead of giving her an angry retort like he would usually do. He felt like his brain had been replaced with cotton and nothing she had said made any sense to him. He was too numb to feel anything, let alone anger…

And, at this, his mom started sobbing.

Ok, he had no idea what was going on.

Masaru gently enveloped his crying wife’s shoulders and led her away from Katsuki’s bed, helping her sit down on the visitor’s couch before walking back towards his son. He had a sympathetic look on his tired face, and now that Katsuki thought about it, he looked about as disheveled as his mother.

“Don’t take her screaming to heart”, he said gently, his hands shoved in his pockets. “She’s been stressing over you. We all have”.

Katsuki simply stared at him, too drugged and confused to offer a response. Masaru shifted his weight from leg to leg.

“You were doing fine after the first surgery, but then you started developing a fever. You had a fever dream and your trashing around tore your stitches and reopened your injury. They had to rush you to the OR. The doctors think the fever itself might have been caused by the…”, he swallowed dry, as if nauseous. “*Impalement* injury. Infection was always a risk because of the intrusive nature of the wound. They said you were feeling constant pain, which is expectable, but it could also signal an infection. They also agreed that your broken arms might have contributed to the fever. Some sort of, um, bone infection as well”.

Katsuki continued to stare at him through glassy eyes.

“They had to call Recovery Girl in to help with the surgery again, so it will take a little while until you recover enough for her to heal your arms for good. You’ll have to stay here for a little longer because they want to keep a close eye on how the…”, he cleared his throat, “*injury* heals. In case more complications happen”.

It took Katsuki a little while to completely understand what he was being told, and once he did, he sighed loudly, closing his eyes.

“This *sucks*”, he groaned, still hating how off his voice sounded.

“I know, son, but…”, Masaru took a deep breath. “Honestly, I’m just glad you’re alive. You had us so worried, Katsuki, you have no idea. Your mom was almost *arrested*”.

That caught his attention.

“Wha’?” he frowned, turning his head to look at Mitsuki, who was sitting on the couch at the corner of the room and seeming to be recomposing herself.

“Yes”, Masaru nodded emphatically, as if he knew that was the sort of information that would catch his son’s interest. “She… slapped a police officer because they wouldn’t let her in the room. They even cuffed her, but All Might apologized on her behalf and explained the situation, so they let her go. No charges pressed”.

“Di’ ya film it?”, Katsuki scoffed.

“No. You know how she is; the whole thing was over before I could even think of grabbing the phone”, Masaru told him apologetically.

Katsuki let out a half-hearted snort.

“Slow”, he and Mitsuki said at the same time.

Masaru sighed.

“Come on, now. You both know it was better for me not to film it. They could use that evidence against you if they did press charges, you know”, he craned his neck to look at his wife.

“Shitty excuse”, Katsuki huffed.

“Watch your language, young man”, Masaru said, but his tone was half-hearted as usual. Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“I alm’st died. I ge’ a free pass”, he said simply, still slurring because of his medication. Before his dad could start looking all gloomy and miserable because of what he said, he added: “So, when can I ge’ th’ hell out of th’s place?”

Masaru sighed, looking away.

“Like I said, you’ll have to stay for a bit longer. Until you’re back on your feet”.

Katsuki tried not to roll his eyes again, just because his dad looked really tired and sad.

“Yeah. And how m’ch longer are we talkin’?”

There was an awkward pause during which his dad looked very uncomfortable. Then, he removed one of his hands from his pocket in order to adjust his glasses back up the bridge of his nose, which indicated this was about to get serious.

Great. Katsuki was definitely too high on pain meds for this.

“Son”, he started, leaning slightly against the edge of Katsuki’s bed. “What happened to you was very serious. You were unconscious for several days, you needed two surgeries, you almost…”, he shook his head, lowering it.

Flashes of Kaminari’s bloodied face hovering above him and looking scared shitless appeared in his mind again, and Katsuki closed his eyes against the memory.

Fine, yeah. His heart had stopped, and all that crap. He *knew*.

“Yeah”, he said upon his father’s silence, not quite meeting his eyes. “I was told”.

Masaru stared at him for a little while, but Katsuki avoided his gaze, looking up at the ceiling instead.

“So you know that this is a delicate situation. And I am begging you, Katsuki – as your father, and as someone who loves you more than anything in this world. Do *not* push yourself”.

Katsuki glared at him. For once in his life, his father sounded very, very serious.

“I mean it”, he added. “I know how you are. I know how you can get. And me and your mom – we both know that this career you’ve chosen – this career we indulged you on – is very dangerous. We are not idiots like you think. We are well aware of the risks of being a hero, we always were. But we’re also your *parents*. There’s nothing we want more than for you to be happy and safe. And, unfortunately, and much to my despair, we both know that your idea of happiness includes being a hero, which means this wasn’t your last round in a hospital”, he said, sounding like his voice was about to break. “But *please*. Do not put us through this

again because you were too stubborn to listen to your doctors and to stay in bed. Do *not* try to prove your worth by pushing yourself until you nearly die again. Katsuki, I am serious – I don't think my heart can take it", he shook his head, tears pooling in his eyes.

Katsuki frowned. His dad looked really desperate. That, added to the way his mom had just *broken down into sobs,* something he couldn't really remembering ever witnessing before, only added to the seriousness of those words – and of that request.

"Ok", Katsuki said compliantly, worry evident in his voice and in the way he was looking at Masaru. The last thing he wanted was to give his dad a heart attack or something.

Masaru nodded gratefully, tears running down his cheeks as he did so. He removed his glasses and cleaned them on his sweater before taking a step back, looking distraught and upset.

"I need to use the bathroom. I'll give you and your mom some privacy", he announced, and just like that, he walked away from the bed and exited the room.

Everything was silent for the little while that took Mitsuki to stand up from the couch and approach her son again. Once she did – Katsuki silently staring up at the ceiling while he waited, not wanting to be the first one to break the ice –, she stopped beside his bed, staring at him.

After a few seconds, he stared back at her.

They were quiet for a while.

Then, just as he was about to avert his gaze…

"Sorry I yelled at you", she said.

Katsuki's eyebrows immediately arched up.

"That *has* to be a f'rst".

Mitsuki clenched her jaw and closed her eyes, tilting her head to the side as she took a deep, calming breath.

"Listen, brat", she said through gritted teeth, sounding like it was taking every ounce of self-control she had not to snap right at him. "I'm trying really hard to do this, so don't act all cocky with me. Ok?", she gave him a look.

Katsuki narrowed his eyes at her, silent. Waiting.

Mitsuki sighed.

"Like I said – I'm sorry. For yelling, and for – accusing you, and for…", she clenched her jaw again.

Then, her shoulders slumped and she deflated. For the first time, Katsuki noticed how tired she really was.

She seemed defeated, in a way.

“I know I messed up”, she continued, head hanging low, as if she couldn’t quite bring herself to look into her son’s eyes. As if she was *afraid.* Her hands were gripping the metal bar on Katsuki’s bed tightly, knuckles white. “I know I was a shit mother. I always let you do whatever you wanted as a kid. I sucked at giving you limits. You reminded me so much of myself, and I… I didn’t want to smother that. That side of you, that was like me. I took *pride* in that. I was so proud of you, and of the potential I knew you had… And when you became limitless, I started shouting at you and giving you shit for something that deep down I knew was my fault. You were just a kid; you didn’t know any better. And I know I should have taught you”.

It was Katsuki’s turn to clench his jaw.

“But I was wrong”, she shook her head, lifting it and meeting Katsuki’s eyes again. Now that he was a bit more sober – but not completely, *far* from it –, he could see that her eyes were red-rimmed and puffy from crying so much. “I shouldn’t have been proud of you back then”.

Ok. Ouch. He hadn’t seen that one coming.

“Because I’ve been losing my mind with worry for you this past week, yes, and I almost shat myself when I got the call telling me that the boy they recovered barely alive from the rubble was *you*, but nothing – and I mean this – *nothing* has ever, *ever* made prouder of you than what you did at that museum”, she told him fiercely, eyes burning with intensity.

Katsuki stared at her in confusion. Ok, he was definitely not sober enough for this conversation.

“Do you realize this? Katsuki?”, she asked, shaking her head again. “Do you realize that you, a 17-year-old brat who barely even has a proper hero license saved *hundreds* of lives all by yourself? Do you realize the strength of that?”

He blinked up at his mom, frowning.

“Shit, kid”, she ran a hand across her face, shaking her head again and looking torn between crying and laughing. “I mean. *God.* Look at you”, she smiled, but there was a tear running down her cheek.

Katsuki felt confused as fuck, to be honest.

“My little baby boy. My little brat. Going off and saving hundreds before he’s even graduated”, she placed her hands on her hips, staring down proudly at him. “You were really destined for greatness, weren’t you, kid?”, she scoffed, smiling at him affectionately.

Katsuki blinked up at her. He didn’t understand.

“I wish I was a better mom to you”, she continued, the smile dying down from her lips as she stared at the side, avoiding his eyes again. “I wish I had taught you stuff properly. I wish I had taught you how to be confident without being arrogant. I feel like, if I had done a better job, I would have spared you a lot of pain”, she sniffed.

Katsuki’s frown deepened.

“Because c’mon, let’s be real here. I could have disciplined you, and you’d still have turned out great”, she shrugged, meeting his eyes. “There was nothing I, or anyone, could have done to smother that talent you have. That glory”, she scoffed.

She stepped closer to him, running a thumb across his cheek. He realized she was wiping a tear away from his face, but he didn’t understand why he was crying or what had triggered it. He probably wouldn’t have even felt the tear if she hadn’t cleared it away.

“So please, kid. Listen to your old hag and do as she says, at least for once in your life. Live to become the greatest, yeah?”, she told him, emotional and yet somehow still looking fierce. “No one is prouder of you than I am. But I was nearly losing it, Katsuki, I punched a police officer, for god’s sake”.

“Dad said ya slapp’d a p’lice off’cer”, Katsuki protested, and of course that would be the first thing he said after his mom put her heart on display like that. Mitsuki snorted.

“Yeah, no, it was a punch”, she admitted, looking away for a moment. “But legally I shouldn’t say that. So don’t tell anyone, ok?”, she crossed her arms above her chest. “Plus, he totally deserved it”.

Katsuki snorted out a laugh, smirking. His mom smirked back at him.

“But seriously. You don’t have to prove anything to anyone, Katsuki”, she continued, assuming a more serious tone. She placed a hand on his shoulder. “And you really, actually, almost died. So if the doctors tell you you can’t leave just yet, listen to them. If they tell you not to get up, stay in bed. I *mean* it. The more you push yourself, the longer you’ll have to stay here”.

Katsuki stared at the ceiling, a pensive look on his face. He knew his mom was right, and if he had to be honest with himself, he didn’t think he could really bring himself to step out of bed just yet, no matter how hard that was to admit.

But then he thought about Deku, and how he had been forced to stay in a hospital bed for months. Katsuki didn’t think he could pull that off. Laying around doing nothing, being constantly helped and probed and dragged around like a puppet with severed strings… Just the mere thought of it sent shivers down his spine.

The thought of being helpless, of being defenseless. Of being weak.

Maybe he could understand Deku’s frustration a little bit better, now that he was sort of walking in his shoes. Why he had been so angry and pissed every time Katsuki told him to

stay away from a fight; why he had looked so sad and upset every time Katsuki called him useless or weak, even if he didn't really mean the words.

He had never considered that those words could have a different weight in Deku's point of view, because of everything he had been through. Katsuki knew damn well that if any of his shitty friends showed up and called him useless while he laid in a hospital bed after nearly kicking the bucket, he would at least try to kick them in the face. But he wasn't in the state of kicking anyone, let alone in the face, so that would probably make him feel even more frustrated.

He wondered why Deku never did that to him. Why he never fought back, why he never called him out on his bullshit. He would have seen it sooner. He would have stopped it before they got into so many fights, before they danced around each other in that never-ending cyclical waltz they kept pulling whenever they interacted.

But who was kidding? If Deku had kicked him, he would have kicked back. It was in his nature.

He had to do something about that.

Because now… Now he knew better. Now he understood better. And now… Maybe he could finally bring their waltz to an end. With no more kicking this time.

"Katsuki? Can you hear me?", his mom called, waving a hand in front of his eyes. She was frowning in concern at him, and Katsuki realized he had been zoning off for a while.

Before he could say anything to justify himself – which would probably take him a while, since he was still under a lot of pain meds – his mom gave his shoulder a squeeze and offered him a tired smile, seeming resigned.

"You should go back to sleep. We can talk about this later, all right?", she said, uncharacteristically soft. Katsuki found it really weird and unsettling, but he didn't exactly dislike it. Maybe he was too drugged to dislike anything in that moment.

When he didn't respond, she snapped her fingers in front of his eyes.

"Oi, brat. Did you hear me?", she asked a bit more abruptly. Katsuki couldn't help but to smirk softly, tiredly – *that* was the Mitsuki he knew.

"Yeah, I heard ya", he slurred, half-groggy, half-falling-asleep. "Don' die, be great. I got th' most of'it, we don' need t' talk about it 'gain. I know y' get a'kward".

Mitsuki gave him an amused scoff.

"And *don't disobey your doctors*, either", Mitsuki added again for good measure, authority written all over her tone. "I mean it, Katsuki. I know we're having a moment here, but if I learn that you as much as scratched your butt without a nurse's permission, I *will* be slapping you".

Katsuki snorted a sleepy laugh.

“Yeah. ‘kay”.

“Good. Oh, just so you know”, she added as his eyes slipped shut. He blinked them open again sluggishly, a bit annoyed that she had told him to sleep only to keep talking. “They will transfer you to UA once you’re stable enough. We all agreed that this way you’ll be safer, and it will be easier to keep an eye on you. In case…”, she trailed off.

Katsuki frowned. *In case a villain attacks? But if they’re visiting, isn’t it because this whole thing is done?*

“Is th’ inv’stigation ov’r?”, he asked, frowning again. Mitsuki nodded, seeming uncomfortable.

“Yeah. Turns out the terrorist group wasn’t all that big. The ones that didn’t die in the explosion were captured in the past few days. Now that everyone’s either dead or locked up, there’s no reason you can’t get visitors. But we all agreed that you, as well as me and your dad, would feel safer if… You were somewhere protected. With people to watch over you”.

“Th’r’s people watchin’ over me h’re”, Katsuki pointed out. Mitsuki rolled her eyes.

“Yeah, I mean people who can do a bit more than wave a scalpel around in case a villain attacks. Which probably won’t happen, but I’d rather be safe than sorry when it comes to your trouble-magnet ass”, she jested.

Katsuki offered a tiny, barely hearable chuckle in return. His eyes slipped back shut out of their own accord, tired, but before he could start drifting off, he felt his mom’s fingers running across his hair. Which was a bit weird.

She had never done that before in his life – all he ever got were rough ruffling of his hair and joking pinches, hard playful shoves and tough teasing around. There had never been caresses at all, let alone this gentle.

A pang of anxiety made his heart speed up. Maybe this wasn’t really his mom. Maybe this was an impostor, waiting for him to put his guard down so she could attack him and finish him off, like Aizawa had done…

Wait, how did he even survive that? Had that been a dream? Or was this the dream? His mom was being uncharacteristically tender towards him, so maybe *this* was the dream. But again, Aizawa wouldn’t really hurt him, would he? So maybe *that* was the dream. Except he didn’t hurt him out of his own free will, the villain had forced him to do it… But his mom had just told him the villain was dead… So which one was the truth? How could he know?

“Mom?”, he called, eyes still closed, but a frown painting his brow.

He, once again, hated how he sounded, but this time more than ever – with a maternal hand caressing his hair, he felt like a lost little kid who was afraid of the monsters under his bed. Which had never been the case. Even as a tiny child, Katsuki had always vowed to kick the ass of whichever monster that had taken residence under his bed.

So why was he feeling so scared and helpless now? Why had he fallen so low?

“Yeah?”, his mom replied, and Katsuki couldn’t really bring himself to form the question he wanted to ask. It was so embarrassing. It was so ridiculous.

He felt so weak. And his mom was the one person Katsuki made a hard point of never allowing himself to show weakness to.

“What is it, Katsuki?”, Mitsuki urged when he didn’t say anything but remained noticeably awake, despite his closed eyes.

Katsuki swallowed dry. He knew he wouldn’t be able to sleep unless he got an answer, but at the same time, he knew he couldn’t ask the question without ridiculing himself. Without making himself vulnerable. And he hated it.

“Whatever it is, you can say it”, Mitsuki offered upon his silence, her hand stilling on his scalp. “Since you saved the day like a champ and didn’t die in the process, you get a hundred days of free-pass to say whatever the hell you want without getting your mouth slapped for it. How does that sound?”

Katsuki snorted another weak laugh. That felt more like their usual dynamic.

“Ya nev’r slap m’ mouth an’way, old hag”.

“Just your head”.

“Yeah”.

A scoff.

“C’mon, brat. Spit it. You made me curious”, she urged after a few moments, sounding sincere.

Katsuki sighed. Maybe if he just let the pain killers and the tiredness take over, he could pretend he didn’t care about the embarrassment of what he wanted to know. If he phrased it in a way that didn’t make him sound like a weak loser, he might even fool himself at the end of the day.

“Th’ v’llain in th’ aud’torium”, he swallowed, not opening his eyes. “Th’ one who chang’d em’tions”.

“Hm”.

“He died?”

There was a pause.

“Yeah. He was too close to the bomb when it went off”.

Katsuki lied very still for a moment, processing his mother's words. He needed to be 100% certain.

"Ya sure?"

"Well, yeah. That's what the police told us".

Yeah, that didn't really reassure him.

"W's th're a body?"

Another pause.

"Katsuki…", a warning.

"Was th're?", he finally reopened his eyes, looking up at his mother.

She gave him a weird look that he couldn't quite figure out. She seemed extremely uncomfortable, out of a sudden.

"Not a *whole* body", she sighed, looking uncharacteristically nauseous. "But enough to attest that he was dead. For good".

Katsuki stared at her and then at the side for a while before his eyelids started to droop closed again, tired. He allowed himself to relax against the bed and the pillows, sighing sleepily. His mind was easier, now that he knew he was definitely safe. And having an easy mind was why he ended up blurting out:

"N' one attack'd me, right?"

Shit. He hadn't meant to go there. Fucking drugs screwing up his inhibition. They also happened to screw up his ability to care, because he was unusually calm, even after embarrassing himself.

"What?", Mitsuki asked, confused, and screw it. He had already started this talk – he might as well carry on through it.

"Wh'le I was here. In th' h'spital. No one att'cked me, right?", he slurred.

There was yet another pause.

"No, Katsuki", Mitsuki said, worried. "No one attacked you. You were being escorted this whole time. They didn't let us see you precisely because security was so tight. Your teachers stayed with you through it all. They even took turns".

Katsuki nodded sluggishly, relaxing further. Ok. So Aizawa trying to murder him had been the dream, instead of his mom being nice to him. For some reason, that new certainty made his chest feel warm and fuzzy. It was… It was probably the drugs.

“’Kay”, he sighed, sagging against his pillows with already closed eyes. He was feeling even calmer now. Calmer and… dizzy.

“Just…”, Mitsuki said, tired. Her tone had definitely shifted from the lighthearted interaction from before into something more somber at her son’s off-putting question. “Try to catch some sleep, all right? You need all the rest you can get”.

Katsuki nodded again – or at least he thought he did. He couldn’t really tell, anymore – the relief that overwhelmed him upon figuring out what was dream and what was reality had made his brain shut down into a dreamless sleep almost immediately.

He woke up to red hair and hushed whispers.

“Shh, I think you woke him up”.

“Well, that nurse guy said he was about to wake up soon, how is this my fault?”

“Because you can’t stay quiet to save your life”.

“You’re the one who’s been staring at him fixedly for like, ten minutes”.

“That doesn’t wake up anyone up!”

“How do you know that?”

“Ugh, just be quiet”.

“How do you know that?! Who did you stare at in their sleep?!”

“*Stop* it, Kirishima –“

“Bakugouuuuuuu”, a female voice said softly from beside him.

Katsuki turned his head towards the voice, blinking a few times. Pink and black painted his vision, but it took him a few moments before he could make sense of the blurry shape in front of him.

It was Mina.

Katsuki's heart immediately sped up as a rush of memory overwhelmed him.

"I'll stop him –", Sero tried to rush to the face-mask villain, meaning to drag him away from the stage.

"No!", Mina held him back, dragging him away. "There's no time, let's go!"

"R-Raccoon Eyes", Katsuki croaked out, trying to shift positions on the bed before he remembered he shouldn't move too much. Mina's eyes were full of tears.

"Oh my god, Bakugou!", she squealed, emotional, looking like she desperately wanted to hug him but knew better than to do that – not because of his temper and possibly grumpy reaction, but because of his still healing wounds. "You're finally awake!"

Katsuki blinked and ran his eyes around the room, trying to catch sight of his other visitors. Kirishima was there, by his other side, as well as Sero, who was standing in front of the bed. He couldn't help but to frown slightly, noticing a few people were missing.

He looked at the door, secretly hoping to find… *someone* else arriving, or waiting there. Now that he was finally allowed visitors, there was no reason for Deku not to stop by, right? But as he searched, he found there was no one else there – just the three friends, gathered around his bed. Sighing, Katsuki turned back to them.

"How long 've you shitheads been standing here watchin' me sleep?", he groaned, voice raspy because of his dry throat. Mina let out a wet chuckle, grasping the bar beside the bed with a vengeance since she couldn't grab Katsuki's actual, very much casted hand.

"Oh, man, I gotta say it's a *relief* to see you're still yourself", Kirishima let out a laugh, grabbing the bar on the *other* side of the bed. "They said you bashed your head pretty bad and this is like, the third time in a year, so we were worried".

"A whole *building* dropped on him", Sero commented, sounding more serious than usual. "It's a surprise his head wasn't in a worse state".

"I never thought I would actually be grateful that you have a thick head, Bakugou", Mina jested, even if she still sounded emotional – which kind of ruined the joke. Katsuki still glared at her for good measure.

"*Oi*".

"But for real, man", Kirishima drew his attention again, the only one bold enough to reach out and touch his shoulder. Katsuki thought he would hate it, but he actually found comfort in the touch. "We're *really* glad your head was thick enough to save your life".

Mina and Sero chuckled friendly. Katsuki rolled his eyes.

"Just you wait until I'm out of this shitty bed. I'll make each and every one of you pay for these shitty jokes", he huffed, but it was half-hearted.

This was because this sort of banter was actually making him feel a bit better – a bit more back to normal. His friends weren't treating him like he was a criminal about to break out, like Aizawa had done, or like he would snap his spine in half if he as much as sneezed, like All Might had done. They weren't being weirdly nice to him like his mom. They were treating him like they always did – teasing, and jesting, and overall being idiots. Idiots Katsuki enjoyed being around, even if he didn't vocalize it much.

And yeah, he had liked that new side of his mom (even if he'd never talk about that to anyone), but being treated normally by his friends was something else. It distracted him from the fact that he was in a very vulnerable position, all broken and bruised on a hospital bed. As long as they kept the teasing and the jokes up, he could almost pretend he didn't feel any shame for being seen in this state – he could almost pretend this was just a regular day after class.

"But how are you doing, Bakugou?", Sero asked, leaning forwards so that he would support his elbows on the foot of Katsuki's bed. "I mean, we all know you were in a pretty bad shape, but are you… You know. Still in pain?"

Katsuki huffed, shifting his head. Of course, his luck was short-lived. The jokes were over. Back to reality. He didn't even know why he bothered to pretend, anyway.

"They're giving me pretty good pain killers", he admitted, a bit too worn out and disappointed to try and keep up a strong façade that would make him say something in the lines of 'whining about pain is for losers'. "But it doesn't hurt all that much now", he added as an afterthought, *just in case*.

He wasn't lying, though. The first times he had woken up, it had been due to a decrease of pain medication in his system – the agony had pushed him back to consciousness. Ever since he woke up to All Might by his side, however, that hadn't been the case. This time, it seemed that his wakefulness had been provoked by his friends' inability to stay quiet when visiting someone in the hospital rather than his brain reacting to the discomfort.

"We were so *worried* about you", Mina said, taking his other shoulder in a mimic of Kirishima. This made him slightly uncomfortable, but he couldn't exactly run away. "I mean, everything happened so fast, and then everything blew up and the building fell down, and then Mid–"

"*Mid-chaos*", Kirishima cut her off with a warning in his voice. Katsuki, still a bit too out of it because of the pain killers, turned his head sluggishly to look at his friend, barely missing the meaningful look Kirishima was pointing at an ashamed Mina. "We realized you weren't out", Kirishima concluded.

"What we wanted to say", Sero said, stepping closer to him and taking Mina's side. "Is that… That…"

He lowered his head with a sigh, trailing off.

Katsuki frowned.

“We’re really grateful you saved our lives, Bakugou”, Mina provided when Sero remained silent, tears appearing in her eyes again. “Thank you”, she added emphatically, squeezing his shoulder.

“Yes”, Sero nodded, and now *he* was looking emotional too. And serious. Very serious. “I mean, what you did was – it was *incredible*. And like, I’m sure this will make your big head even bigger, but everyone’s talking about how amazing you are. And you totally deserve the praise, because – *dude*”.

Katsuki scoffed, a smirk appearing on his lips.

“But can we agree that, next time, you should escape with us instead of staying back and getting impaled?”, he added, a paradoxical mixture of humor and resentment in his voice. Mina nudged his belly with her elbow.

“Don’t joke about that, idiot”, she reprimanded in a low voice, probably not meaning for Katsuki to hear it. He barely did.

“Sorry, sorry”, Sero chuckled, sounding forced. “I was just trying to lighten the mood. Bakubro is looking real grim”.

“That’s *precisely* because of the impalement! You don’t need to remind him of that!”, Mina scolded with a whisper. Katsuki’s hard-hearing made it hard for him to fully understand what she was saying, but he could have a general idea from the tone she was using and from the disapproving look on her face.

“It’s ok”, Katsuki mustered, not really thinking about his words before he said them, which apparently was becoming a habit. “Not plannin’ on getting impaled again. Also, I said this stuff is pretty good. I can’t even feel m’ face right now”, he added before his brain could catch up with the possible consequences for that, and once again, god damn these inhibition issues he was having.

Mina and Kirishima exchanged a look.

“*No*”, Kirishima said emphatically before the girl even opened her mouth.

“Oh, come on!”, Mina protested.

“We agreed on that, Mina!”, Kirishima continued.

“That’s not fair”.

“I can’t believe you’re making me be the sensible one! We’re not supposed to be arguing in front of our friend who barely escaped death, *or* making fun of him while he’s drugged!”

“See? You didn’t say anything about taking pictures –“

“Because that’s *implied*!”

“I did that last time and you enjoyed it!”

“Uh, guys”, Sero interrupted. “I think Bakubro fell asleep again”.

Katsuki blinked his eyes open, not having realized he’d closed them.

“Nope, still here”, he said quickly. “Just tired of listenin’ to your shitty arguing”, he added defensively.

Kirishima gave him a fond chuckle, tapping his shoulder.

“We should probably let you rest. Aizawa sensei told us not to wear you out too much, and I’m pretty sure he’ll have our heads on silver trays if something happens to a single hair on your head because of us”.

Katsuki frowned at him.

“Watcha mean?”, he asked.

“Oh, nothing much, apart from the fact he was there with you while the paramedics were trying to prevent you from dying”, Sero huffed sarcastically. This time, Mina slapped his arm.

“What’s *wrong* with you?”, she asked angrily, loud enough for Katsuki to understand it this time, and glaring at the tape boy.

Sero looked ashamed again, facing away, and Katsuki felt, for some weird reason, a need to intervene. The last thing he needed was for their friends to start tip-toing around him like his teachers had been doing, and he wasn’t really much into arguments in which he didn’t participate directly.

“It’s no’ like I don’t know I was pr’tty fucked up”, he offered.

Mina stared at him with confusion written all over her emotional eyes whereas Sero kept avoiding to look at him.

“Uh… Aizawa sensei’s just worried about you, man”, Kirishima concluded awkwardly, shrugging and trying to diverge his attention from the other friends. “I mean, we all were. But like Sero said, he was there for the worst of it, so… He’s been stressed out. Midoriya too. *Especially* because of the whole investigation stuff that was going on”.

Katsuki blinked for a few seconds, trying to understand why that rang a bell. Then, he recalled his conversation with his mom, and the information about the investigation being over and his transfer back to UA. That was the reason why his friends and his parents were allowed visit him, but Katsuki had been too out of it to ask his mom about the details.

“How was it?”, he asked, head still feeling like mashed potato. Kirishima tilted his head.

“What? The investigation?”

“Yeah”, Katsuki sighed, closing his eyes for a second. When he reopened them, Kirishima was giving him a weird look.

“Look, you don’t need to worry about that”, his best friend said after a few seconds, and there was something off about his voice. “Everything’s solved. The villains who managed to escape were arrested and interrogated, and they didn’t allow you to have visitors until they were a hundred percent sure that there was no one else left in the group and no risk of another attack”.

Katsuki sighed again, exasperated.

“’m not worried”, he grunted. “I j’st wanna know how it went. M’ mom just told me the basic”.

Mina and Kirishima shared a look.

“Maybe you should rest a bit more before we talk about that”, Mina offered, giving him a sympathetic smile. Katsuki frowned.

What the fuck were they hiding?

“Why?”, he grunted again, shifting his head to look at her. His eyes unadvisedly averted towards the door behind her before they focused back on her worried face.

Mina sighed, opening and closing her mouth in an attempt to search for the words she wanted to say. In the end, it was Sero who answered.

“It’s because you’ve been taking power naps for the entirety of this conversation, man”, he spoke up, sounding uncomfortable. “You’re clearly too tired for this”.

Katsuki stared at him. Sero finally met his eyes, and there was something alien there, in the gaze of his friend who was usually so lighthearted and well-humored. Something grim that Katsuki didn’t really recognize.

It felt wrong. Sero was usually the one who made jokes and sassy comments, alongside Kaminari and Kirishima. Kirishima was clearly trying to be lighthearted and supportive, as he always did, but Sero… It was like he wasn’t even trying. And while he always gave Katsuki shit, all his attempts so far had been tone deaf. More importantly, he wasn’t the type to mope and look so…

Sad.

Mina and Kirishima exchanged another look before Kirishima hummed and scratched the back of his head.

“Uh… Hey, um, Mina”, Kirishima said awkwardly. “I’m feeling really hungry. Wanna go to that vending machine outside with me so we can grab some chips?”

“Yeah, yeah, I’ll go with you”, Mina said with a tiny smile, walking towards the door and holding it open for Kirishima. “Hey, Bakugou, we’ll… be right back”, she offered as a shitty excuse, but before Katsuki could call her out for it, she and Kirishima were already out of the room, the door clicking dully behind them.

Sero sighed and rolled his eyes before taking Mina's place, closer to Katsuki's head. Katsuki stared at him with suspicion in his eyes, waiting for the boy to say whatever it was he wanted to say – since that was obviously the reason why Kirishima and Mina left in the first place.

A few moments of awkward silence passed, during which Sero looked anywhere but at Katsuki's general direction while Katsuki glared up at him as viciously as he could, promptly making an effort to *not* blink his eyes for too long and risk falling asleep (again).

Eventually, Sero sighed again, lowering his head for a moment before meeting Katsuki's fixed gaze.

"Look, man", he said, and Katsuki hated how alien the melancholic look on his face seemed. "I'm just… Having a hard time coping with everything that happened. The guys know that, and they probably want me to talk to you about it, but we don't need to have this conversation if you don't want to".

Katsuki scoffed. While he appreciated the offer, he also wanted to get this over with before his paranoid brain could start coming up with theories that Sad Sero was actually an impostor.

"Talk ahead, Seaweed Hair", he grunted. "'s not like I can run away or someth'ng".

"Yeah, I know", Sero said, uncharacteristically serious. "This is why I don't want to force you into this. As least not until you're well enough to walk away if you feel like it".

Katsuki studied his face for a moment, eyes narrow.

"Wha's really going on?", he asked, suspicious. Sero lowered his head again, biting at his lower lip – in yet another alien manner.

A beat. During the moment it took Sero to respond, the only sound in the room was coming from the machines attached to Katsuki, but they were dull, as if beeping from a distance. Katsuki was too focused on his friend to put any thought into it, but he had to admit that the muffled way things were sounding was starting to piss him off. The only reason he was able to understand what people told him was because the room was very, very quiet and usually his visitors stood and sat directly in front of him, meaning he could see their lips while they talked.

"We…", Sero started, not looking at him and seeming awkward. "Almost lost you", he admitted, shrugging.

He sounded like he was making an incredible effort to let the words out, which was why Katsuki didn't respond with 'yeah, and I have been told that a million times already'.

"It was pretty damn close, man. And I was right there, you know? You –", he scoffed, shaking his head. "You threw me out right before the whole thing blew up, and you like – you *trusted* I'd be able to grab everyone and take them to safety", he looked at Katsuki, serious.

Katsuki frowned.

“Yeah”, he shrugged – or tried to, given his current condition. “I knew you could do it. You were th’ best shot I had”.

Sero scoffed again, hands gripping the bar by the bed hard enough for his knuckles to go white.

“Yeah”, he said simply, bitterly, as if that was a good enough explanation for his sour mood. His head was lowered between his tensed-up shoulders.

Katsuki waited for him to continue. He didn’t.

“I don’t get it”, Katsuki admitted, a bit annoyed and definitely confused as hell. Sero looked at him. “You’re piss’d I trusted you?”

It was Sero’s time to squint.

“*What*?”, he asked, sounding almost offended that was Katsuki’s conclusion. “*No*, dude. I’m just – I –“, he hesitated swallowing dry.

Katsuki watched him.

“Look”, Sero sighed again, sounding tired. “I’m just glad you’re alive. And I’m – I’m glad you trust me”.

Katsuki continued to watch him.

Sero met his eyes again, seeming a bit embarrassed.

“All I’m trying to say is – Well. We all know you’re a bit of a hothead”, he shrugged. “And I guess deep down I always knew you don’t actually – hate us all or something, and you don’t actually think we’re useless extra cockroaches or whatever. But, I don’t know”.

Katsuki frowned.

“You’re not makin’ any sense”, he complained. But maybe Sero *was* making sense and his head was the one too fuzzy by the painkillers for him to understand what he was saying. He wasn’t about to let the boy know that, though.

Sero sighed again, frustrated. Then, he forced himself to look at Katsuki.

“Thanks for trusting me”, he said, almost aggressively.

Katsuki frowned.

“O…k…?”

Sero let go of the bar and crossed his arms above his chest.

“I mean, that was what I wanted to say. That I’m thankful that you saved my life, and that you trusted me enough to save other peoples’ lives”, he concluded, staring at his feet. “Also,

sorry I called you ugly that one time".

Katsuki snorted out a weak laugh at this, ignoring the dull pain that erupted in his torso at the motion. He was still too high on painkillers to pay it any mind.

"I mean it!", Sero protested at Katsuki's reaction, but he looked a bit less grim now. A bit more like himself. "That was all I could think about while they wouldn't let us see you".

"Tha' you called me *ugly*?", Katsuki frowned, still smirking.

"That I wanted to apologize for that and I might not get the chance", Sero huffed, looking away in embarrassment again.

Katsuki's smile withered slowly. The reality of what had happened – of how *close* he'd been to losing his life – hit him like bricks once again.

"Look, man", Sero swallowed again. "I don't usually get this sappy, but –"

"Yeah, I'm findin' this really weird".

"*But*", Sero looked at him. "It was really bad. Everyone was losing their minds. Kami…", he sighed, trailing off.

Yeah, Katsuki had been wondering about him, too. About him, and… someone else. His eyes once again found the door of the room, but there was no one there. He saw Mina and Kirishima very-not-subtly staring at him through the glass wall, but they jumped away from view as soon as Katsuki made eye-contact.

"He's not doing so well", Sero concluded, unaware.

For some reason, that made Katsuki's stomach twist a bit.

"I can imag'ne".

"Yeah", Sero nodded. "He'll probably visit you later. And I'm sorry I'm being all moody and all, but –", he bit at his lower lip again. "You're my friend. You know?", he shrugged. "I don't think I was dealing well with the fact that you might… not be around anymore".

It was Katsuki's time to look away.

"That's why I keep… talking about what happened", he swallowed dry. "A bit too bluntly sometimes. It pisses Mina off. You know, the whole, uh, mentioning your state thing, and talking about the… uh. The injury", he cleared his throat. "Sorry about bringing those things up, by the way. I don't know – uh, if that makes you uncomfortable or something. I should probably stop. It's just – for me, talking about it makes it a bit…"

He trailed off. Katsuki stared at him, waiting for him to continue.

"A bit less like a nightmare, you know? A bit easier to… overcome. The other guys have their own ways to cope. You probably can't tell, but Kiri was *manly* sobbing his eyes out

earlier today", he smiled sadly.

Katsuki narrowed his eyes, but hummed his acknowledgment.

"You don' have t' worry about it", he said. "I don' give a shit if you mention it or not".

Sero let out a sincere chuckle at this, probably the first real one ever since Katsuki woke up.

"Well, I figured it would be better to explain it to you", he shrugged. Katsuki sighed.

"Good. Now tha' we're settled, can you stop acting so weird?", he huffed. If Sero's cheeks became a little bit pinker, Katsuki was too drugged to notice – or to pay it any mind.

"Yeah, sorry about that. Guess I was just too worried about you".

Katsuki huffed again, even if Sero's words made his heart a little bit warmer.

"'m not gon' be taken down by some extra", he said out of habit, but half-heartedly. "You can't get rid of me that easily".

Sero smirked somewhat fondly at his friend, watching as his eyes slipped closed in spite of himself again. Katsuki was obviously tired, even if he would never admit that – or, in fact, recognize that. Sero took that as his cue.

"You want me to ditch those guys so you can get some rest?", Sero offered.

Katsuki scoffed.

"Tch. All I've been doing so far is restin'".

"Well, that sounds like a wise choice", Sero raised his eyebrows. "Since you were like. You know. Pretty, uh, messed up, and all that. And I know I just apologized for calling you ugly, but you really look like you could use some sleep, man".

Katsuki snorted, smirking slightly before letting it drop into a half-grimace.

"I'm fed up with sleepin'", he complained, even though his eyes were closed and his breathing seemed to be evening out.

Sero offered him another fond smile, one which was in no way rid of concern and the tiniest hint of guilt.

"Well, guess I'll head outside and let the guys know I'm doing better now that we talked", he announced, knowing that Katsuki was too proud to admit he wanted to rest – he would probably end up passing out from tiredness in the middle of their conversation instead. Sero would have to pretend he was the one who opted to leave.

"Okay", was Katsuki's mumbled response.

"I'll also tell the others who are here to see you to come visit some other time, ok?"

“’kay”, Katsuki mumbled sleepily.

Sero watched him for a few more moments.

“Also, Midoriya asked us to tell you he’s sorry he hasn’t been around”.

But Katsuki was already fast asleep and unable to provide an answer.

Katsuki woke up in the middle of the night, alone.

“Ice chips”, he mumbled sleepily, only half-awake. “Deku, can you fetch me some ice chips…”

No answer. He fell asleep again before jolting back into wakefulness.

“Aizawa s’nsei”, he croaked out. “’re ya there?”

Silence. He was completely alone.

He ended up falling asleep again, thirsty.

Next time he woke up, for what felt like the hundredth loop on a groundhog day, Kaminari’s blurry face was there.

Katsuki groaned.

“You guys takin’ turns creeping ov’r me or s’mething?”, he complained, sighing. And then, something he had never anticipated happened.

Kaminari burst into sobs.

Katsuki frowned, worried, as his friend’s shoulders rattled and he covered his face with his hands. It was clear he was trying to hold back his tears, but he was failing miserably – and then Jirou was there, by his side, hands on his shoulders to offer him support.

“There, there”, she whispered, in her usual serious tone, running a soothing hand up and down Kaminari’s shaking back. “It’s ok”.

Kaminari finally uncovered his face, eyes red-rimmed and puffy, indicating this wasn’t the first time he burst into tears recently. Katsuki’s frown deepened.

“Wha’?”, he asked, trying to sound natural despite the fact that he was: 1. Pretty much still very high on pain meds; and 2. Worried about his friend’s mental state, since he knew exactly why Kaminari seemed to be so shaken.

He had been there. He could still remember, with a twinge of embarrassment, how hard he had broken down on the day he watched someone else flat line. Someone close.

Someone he’d been putting a real effort on not thinking about, because that someone hadn’t shown up to visit once, and Katsuki didn’t know what he had done wrong this time.

Just to be safe, his eyes travelled the room like they had done on his last visiting session, but he found no one other than Jirou and Kaminari in there. He turned his gaze back to them, finding that his friend was starting to regain his composure while Jirou still comforted him.

Her ears seemed to have healed. That shouldn’t be such a big surprise, since Katsuki was in this damn hospital long enough for that to happen, but it was still… nice to know.

“Sorry, man”, Kaminari croaked out, voice wet and emotional. He kept sniffing and trying to rub his tears away from his blotted face with the back of his hand. “I’m – I’m s-sorry. I told myself I wouldn’t break down, but really, god, it’s so good to hear you *complain*, Bakugou, you have no idea”, he admitted.

Katsuki scoffed.

“Gonna rem’mber you said that”, he advised with a tiny smirk.

The jest didn’t help diffusing the tension. Kaminari continued to sniff and Jirou rolled her eyes, but there was a fond yet equally guilty look on her tired face.

Katsuki had to admit he was starting to feel a bit fed up with that look on his friends’ faces. He wished he could do something to wipe it away, especially because he knew the looks were only there because of him.

“I – I don’t know if they told you what happened –“, Kaminari started again.

“They did”, Katsuki interrupted him before he could start with that same old ‘we almost lost you’. “I know”.

The silence that fell in the hospital room was very tense.

“Well…”, it was Jirou who cut it, letting go of Kaminari and taking a step closer to the bed. “How are you? With all that, I mean?”

“All wha’?”, Katsuki frowned.

She gave him a slightly suspicious look.

“Didn’t you just say they told you?”, she raised an eyebrow.

Katsuki scoffed again.

“You wanna know if ‘m fine with th’ fact my heart stopped and I almost died?”, he asked nonchalantly, barely noticing the way Kaminari flinched beside him. “Yeah. Doin’ great”.

Jirou stared at him, gaze intense.

“We were very worried, you know”, she settled for saying.

“I can tell”, Katsuki sighed.

“Like, *really* worried”, Jirou emphasized.

Katsuki stared at her.

“I know”, he replied.

A pause.

“I know you’ve probably been hearing this a lot”, she continued, voice tight. “But you were amazing back there. And thank you – for saving our lives”.

Katsuki nodded, feeling a bit uncomfortable.

“Yeah, ‘s not a big deal”, he mumbled.

Ok. To be fair, he was a person who grew up surrounded by and constantly covered in praise. “You’re amazing” here, “sugoi” there, “he has a great future ahead of him”, “he as an incredible quirk”, “he’s going to make a great hero someday”, yadda yadda yadda. He would be a liar if he said he didn’t *like* the praise – especially when it came from a certain *someone* –; he was too used to it to pretend it bothered him.

But in this specific case, the praise felt… sour. It was something difficult to understand or to even think too much about, since his brain felt like mush every time he woke up, but he didn’t really like it. Maybe it was because he was being praised by something that was

keeping him stuck inside a hospital. Maybe it was because he *had* almost died, despite the fact he hadn't been sober enough to properly take that in just yet.

Maybe it was because he hadn't done it for the praise.

For the first time ever, he hadn't really thought about how cool everyone would think he was, or how he would prove himself to be better than everyone else, or how that would have a positive effect on his hero career. When the disaster happened, all Katsuki had thought about was saving his friends – saving Hatsume. Praise, recognition, and glory were the last things in his mind back then – he hadn't even considered them. They hadn't been his goal or his priority, at all.

And… Katsuki knew where his friends were coming from. They were probably thanking him precisely because they knew he had prioritized their rescue. They were probably praising him to make him feel a bit less pissed he was stuck in a bed and being pumped up with meds all day long.

He should be glad. He really should. He should be happy with their thanks and with their comments on how amazing he was.

But he wasn't.

He didn't really know why, but there was something bothering him.

"Dude", Kaminari responded, bringing him out of his introspection. "Of *course* it was a big deal".

"What you did…", Jirou shook her head in support. "It was big, Bakugou. Bigger than a lot of heroes your age accomplished".

"Did you know they are comparing you to All Might?", Kaminari continued. "They're calling you the next *All Might*, dude. That's – That's *huge*".

"And", Jirou shrugged. "That's pretty much the first step on your stupid plan of surpassing him, right?"

But Katsuki wasn't listening to them anymore.

The next All Might.

Red and orange lighting sparkled around his limbs, running across his body, making the hairs of his arms stand up and electric shivers run down his spine.

Fuck. Fuck, god damn it. God damn it to fucking hell.

"Bakugou…?", Jirou frowned, noticing the look on his face and the increasing pace of his heart monitor. "What's wrong?"

He squeezed his eyes shut. So far, he had been able to remember what had happened to him – the villains, the explosion, the building falling. After that, his mind was a fuzzy mess of pain

and flashes, like Kaminari's crying face, or Deku's bloodied face, or Aizawa sensei. But now, things seemed to be clearer in his mind. A missing piece of the puzzle had finally been placed in its gap.

He had used One For All.

He had fucking used One For All, even though he didn't mean to. That was probably why his arms were so fucked up – he had done what Deku did so many times. He had broken his bones because of the quirk. And now people were comparing him to All Might.

No wonder Deku hadn't shown up yet. Katsuki had stolen yet another one of his dreams.

"Kaminari", Jirou called, urgent and serious. "Call the nurse".

"What's going on?!", Kaminari exclaimed.

"Go call the nurse", Jirou repeated.

Katsuki's eyes were darting the room while he thought, and he noticed he was on the verge of hyperventilating. He needed to put his thoughts in order, but it was hard to do that with so many drugs in his system, making his head fuzzy and slow.

"Wai'", he called breathlessly just as Kaminari crossed the room and reached for the doorknob. The boy froze in his tracks, hand outstretched, craning his head to look back at Katsuki.

"Bakugou, you're clearly unwell –" Jirou tried to argue, but Katsuki swallowed dry, ignoring the growing discomfort on his side.

He wasn't sure if it was time for another round of his meds, but he wanted to be as sober as he could, at least for a few moments. He wouldn't be able to do that if Kaminari called a nurse. It seemed that Jirou's request had served to get Katsuki's head away from the increasing panic and back to what really mattered.

"'m ok", he said, even if the words sounded as forced as they felt. One thing at the time. One foot after the other. "Don' wanna go under 'gain".

Jirou gave him a sad, concerned look as she crossed her arms above her chest, frowning.

"Bakugou…", she said in disapproval.

"'m ok", he swallowed dry again. If anything, the pain in his torso was starting to tone down now that he had stopped breathing so fast.

"I don't think –"

"*Stop it*", he mustered out, voice a bit stronger. Jirou flinched but stood her ground, still eyeing him with great worry.

Kaminari hesitantly lowered his arm and approached the bed again, staring at Katsuki as if he was a wounded animal.

“I just – I didn’ know tha’”, he admitted, looking back at Jirou. “The All Might thing. He was h’re just the other day”.

Jirou bit her lower lip and nodded.

“Yeah. He and Aizawa sensei were taking turns watching over you. He didn’t know about it either – it’s all very recent”.

Katsuki hummed.

“We –“, Jirou continued, hesitant. “We only told you because… Um. I remember the villain’s threat. Back at the auditorium”.

Katsuki blinked at her, trying to remember what she was talking about.

“He said you were the explosion boy and that the media would put this on you. I just wanted you to know that they didn’t”, she blinked, looking away. “Everyone who was there was forced to have an interview with the investigators, and we made sure to make it very clear it wasn’t you who set the bombs off”.

Katsuki gave her an amused scoff.

He was really grateful for that. It had definitely been one of his latent worries, one of those he hadn’t found the time to really think about – his dream and the villain’s mockery had been a pretty good indicator of that. He didn’t know how to voice his gratitude properly, though; not without making him sound like an idiot.

(“If you’re expecting a thank you, you should get your head off the clouds”, Katsuki snorted, raising an eyebrow at her.

“I’m definitely not expecting a thank you from you”, Jirou admitted.)

Yeah, ok, fuck it. Just one time wasn’t going to kill him.

(*Bad choice of words*.)

“Thanks, Ears”, he mustered out, looking away before she could give him *that look*. He didn’t know why he had done that – but he knew that, despite being the one who got the worst end out of this entire situation, his friends were worried about him, as well as his parents and his teachers. And frankly, he was *done* worrying people.

He was done seeing the miserable look on their faces when they stared at him.

It took a while for Jirou to respond, and when she did, she sounded shocked.

“It’s… It’s ok, Bakugou”, she stuttered. “Sorry if we freaked you out by dumping too much on you at once”.

That pissed him off a bit.

“I can t’ke it”, he scoffed, annoyed.

“We know, man”, Kaminari was the one who intervened. Katsuki looked at him, finding that he hated how puffy and worried his eyes were.

Flashes of Kaminari’s face, half-covered in blood and looking desperate, staring down at him and yelling something he couldn’t hear –

“And how’re *you* farin’ up?”, Katsuki groaned as he tried to shift on the bed. Not a good idea, but he assumed he was still on enough pain killers for the pain not to be excruciating.

He was wrong. The meds *were* running off, and moving hurt like hell. He decided not to let it show on his face, lest he worry his friends even more.

Kaminari frowned, confused and seemingly taken aback by the question.

“I should be the one asking you that”, he admitted. “You were the one who… Who…”

“You look like shit”, Katsuki pointed out simply before he could finish that sentence.

Kaminari stared at him, mouth opening and closing.

“I – w-well, um, I –“, he stuttered, clearly embarrassed.

“’m just sayin’ because I know”, Katsuki admitted, embarrassed, and thankfully he was pretty much drugged up, otherwise he would have found it a lot harder to be this honest with Kaminari.

Maybe with Kirishima it wouldn’t be so hard, but things were different with Kaminari. They were close, of course, but the boy was way more prone to failing to read the room and teasing at the wrong times, which meant Katsuki didn’t do heart-to-hearts with him too often.

This time was different, however. Not just because his head was a mess of sleepiness, concussion and painkillers, but also because he *knew* what Kaminari had gone through.

“You… know?”, Kaminari frowned, confused.

Katsuki sighed.

“I saw Deku flatline too”.

He was too focused on trying to hide his pain to notice the look Kaminari and Jirou shared.

“I know it sucks. You shouldn’ have needed t’ go through that”, he concluded.

Kaminari gaped at him.

Then, more tears started pooling in his eyes and his face started to scrunch up.

“Oooookay”, Jirou said, walking around the bed so that she could grab Kaminari’s shoulders and lead him away from the bed before he had another breakdown – which seemed to be increasingly close. “Kaminari is taking a break outside. I’ll be right back”.

“Jirou, why is he *acting* like that –“, he asked in a whiny voice.

“Shhh, just wait outside. Grab yourself something to eat and take a breather like we talked, ok?”, she opened the door and pushed him out, closing it behind him with a click and turning on her heels almost immediately.

Katsuki stared at her. She stared back.

Then, she slowly marched back towards the bed, an apologetic look on her face.

“Sorry about that, Blasty. We talked about it before you woke up, but… everyone’s been going through a lot”, she explained. “It’s hard, keeping our feelings at bay after everything that happened”.

Katsuki studied her face. It took his slowed-down reflexes twice longer to identify the sorrow on her expression. In fact, his reflexes were so slow that he didn’t even have it in himself to wonder why he still felt drugged if his drugs were running off.

“’m ok now”, he mumbled out. “You guys don’ have to worry abou’ me”.

“We know”, Jirou smiled. “But we still do. No matter how strong or totally awesome or All Might-like you are, and you can’t stop us”.

Katsuki’s smile fell, and Jirou noticed.

“Sorry”, she said immediately, even if she didn’t know why that subject was bothering him so much. “I’m – sorry”.

Katsuki’s eyes averted towards the door again, before fixing back on Jirou.

“I fuckin’ hate these pain killers”, he dodged the subject, grumpy. “Make m’ head all fuzzy”.

“Well, there was a hole ripped through you barely a week ago, so I think it’s fair that you still need them”, she shrugged, eyes fixed on him. Then, after a beat: “Does it hurt too much?”

Katsuki sighed.

“Wh’never it does, someon’ calls the damn nurse and they knock me ou’ again”, he complained with a huff. “Tha’s why I didn’t want you two to do that”.

Jirou nodded.

“I figured. Must be pretty maddening for you, having to stay here just sleeping and talking to people whenever you wake up, huh?”

Katsuki snorted.

“Yeah. Th’ drugs make me feel too ou’ of it to really care, though”, he admitted.

“Hm”, Jirou hummed, crossing her arms above her chest.

Silence fell between them. Katsuki found his mind starting to drift off, like it had happened back when his mom visited, and when Sero visited… But the pain was becoming stronger. Why was he falling asleep if his side still hurt…

“Wha’s up with Sero?”, Katsuki found his mouth forming the words before he really thought them through. He just needed something to keep his mind stimulated; to keep his brain awake.

Jirou frowned, tilting her head to the side.

“Oh, well. He’s… Hanging in there”, Jirou said. “We were all… You know, pretty shaken by what happened. Me and the others who were with you, especially. You’ll probably get a visit from Hatsume soon, so you might want to prepare for that”.

If fucking Pink Hair shows up here before Deku does I’ll swallow my own pillow, Katsuki thought angrily, surprising himself with the intensity of the intrusive thought.

“Your therapist wanted to visit you too, but when she showed up you were still under that no-visitors policy because of the investigation”, she continued. “She’s worried about you. And we know that that Matsuo guy was her son. So you should expect her to come around some time, too”.

Katsuki faced away from Jirou, staring out the window. The question he couldn’t bring himself to ask lingered unspoken in the air.

Silence stretched. Jirou was standing right beside him, but he couldn’t face her. He didn’t want to.

“Aren’t you going to ask about Midoriya?”, she broke the silence eventually, and Katsuki closed his eyes, not looking at her.

“Wha’ about him?”, he groaned.

There was a pause.

“I’m finding it pretty uncharacteristic of you to not ask about him as soon as you wake up, given everything that happened between you two”.

Katsuki sighed.

“Nothin’ happened between us”.

Jirou snorted sarcastically.

“Yeah. Ok”.

More silence. Katsuki found himself wishing he would drift off again, but now he was too alert to do so. His heart was beating too fast. He felt a bit more like himself.

He realized, with a mortifying blush that rose to his face, that Jirou could probably hear the subtle change in his heartrate from the machine, even if he couldn't. He only ever heard it if the machine was going crazy – whenever his cardiac rhythm was normal, the sound was too soft to be perceptible.

He tilted his face away from her further, embarrassed.

"Ok, guess I'll just tell you about it anyway, thick-head", Jirou sighed, sounding… disappointed? "He's doing fine. He's back to 100%. The only reason why he didn't come here yet is because…"

There it was. Katsuki held his breath in anticipation in spite of himself. Had he been in his perfect senses he would have known that there was no way Jirou would say Deku was mad at him because of the All Might thing and One For All, because she didn't *know* about One For All, but his drugged-up brain convinced him that Deku had made up some sort of generic excuse that even Jirou would buy. And he shouldn't be so upset or so afraid, but he was weak as shit and he had almost died and he was definitely past the point of pretending he didn't care about Deku's opinion or Deku overall. He hadn't *meant* to use One For All, he didn't *ask* for anyone to call him the new All Might. Couldn't Deku see that? Couldn't he comprehend –

"… the medical staff wants you to get better before they let you see each other".

Katsuki's racing thoughts hit the brakes so abruptly his brain lopsided.

He turned his head to look at Jirou, a frown painting his face.

"Wha'?"

Jirou gave him a troubled look, facing away and staring at the wall instead.

"Well", she swallowed dry. "As you can imagine, he was the one most shaken about the whole thing".

Katsuki's brain was probably fuming from the effort he was making to understand this conversation.

"Wha' do you mean?", he squinted.

Jirou… blushed?

"Bakugou", she looked at him, stern. "I know you're oblivious as hell and I *know* you're recovering and probably… drowning in pain meds", she pointed at the IV connected to his broken arms. "But *please.* When Midoriya visits you, don't – don't be an idiot".

Katsuki just looked at her.

“None of us was allowed to visit you until yesterday, so I was with him”, Jirou continued, and her eyes started to look wetter. “We all were with him. In the waiting room. And I saw how he was. It was almost as bad as…”, she shook her head, uncertain. “As back at the training camp”, she resumed in a quieter voice, as if she was afraid just mentioning that would make Katsuki spontaneously combust.

Katsuki opened his mouth to protest, but Jirou stopped him before he could start.

“All I’m saying”, she added quickly. “Is… No matter how oblivious you are, or how stubborn, or how much you think you care about him”, she gave him a serious look. “He also cares about you. So please… Don’t start another fight with him”, she shook her head. “I don’t think either of you can take it right now”.

Katsuki frowned.

“Why’d I fight him?”, he asked, genuinely confused.

Jirou grimaced. She seemed conflicted, as if she knew something Katsuki didn’t, but then her expression softened.

“Because that’s what you two always do”, she shrugged. Katsuki had a feeling that wasn’t the whole truth, but he couldn’t deny she was right. “That’s part of the reason why he wasn’t allowed in yet. They want you to be at the very least able to eat solid food before he can see you. It’s for his mental state, as well as yours”.

Katsuki blinked at her. Realizing he wasn’t really understanding what she was saying, Jirou sighed and took a step closer to the bed.

“All I’m saying is”, she started again. “Seeing you like that, seeing what happened to you, what Kaminari had to do…”, she shook her head. “It messed us up, Bakugou. Really. I… I’m trying to be strong for you because I know how much you hate it when you think people are patronizing you”, she admitted, emotional. “But this is hard for me. For all of us. We thought you were going to die”.

A pregnant pause. Jirou averted her eyes, this time towards the ceiling in an attempt to keep her tears from falling.

“We thought you were going to die because of us”, she added, voice shaky. “And I could make you a whole speech on how glad I am you are alive, but I know you’re not that type of person and I know you probably heard it from everyone who’s visited you so far. So I’m going to tell you something you actually need to hear instead”, she lowered her head from the ceiling to look him in the eye. “Don’t be an idiot”.

Another pause. Katsuki sustained her gaze.

“Because if this is being hard to me, I can’t even *imagine* how hard it is going to be on Midoriya”.

Katsuki let out a soft huff through his nose. This time, he was the one who turned away.

“And now you know why he can’t visit, you can stop looking at that door every other ten seconds”, she added, tone lighter.

Katsuki blinked in embarrassment. Had he really been doing it that often, without even realizing?

“I’m just teasing you, Nitro Brain”, Jirou chuckled when she noticed his reaction, pushing his shoulder lightly. “Wanted to see your face. You get slow when you’re drugged”.

Katsuki frowned, because… Well. He wasn’t feeling so drugged anymore. But he *was* feeling slow. And sluggish. And everything that came with being filled with pain meds all the time. But there was also pain, which confirmed the meds were gone.

“But really. Just for good measure, I’m glad you didn’t kick the bucket”, Jirou continued after an awkward pause, clearly trying to diffuse the tension.

The worry was still at his brain, but it was slipping away from his attention like sand now that Jirou continued to talk. He tried to mark that non-related-to-drugs-slowness subject as ‘something to discuss later’, but it was hard to concentrate on anything. It was like his thoughts were water on a river – flowing and floating away from his focus unstoppably.

“I know”, Katsuki told her sarcastically, trying his best to concentrate on the conversation. “Wha’ would you do without me, right”.

“A lot less stress-relief playlists, that’s for sure”, Jirou smirked back.

“Tch”, Katsuki smirked.

A comfortable silence fell between them.

“I think I’ll bring Kaminari back”, Jirou announced after a few moments. “He’s one of the people who need to see you before their guilt becomes spontaneous combustion”, she turned to leave.

“How’s”, Katsuki added quickly before she could get too far. “How’s he… doin’?”

Jirou stared at him.

“I mean, I don’t remember”, he admitted with a shrug, which turned out way more painful than he had expected. Kaminari definitely would have to be his last visit before they hooked him up to the good stuff again. “Aizawa sensei told me what happened, but I don’t know the details”.

Jirou bit her lower lip, seeming conflicted.

It took longer than he had expected for her to reply.

“Aizawa sensei, Ochako, Kaminari and the paramedics went after you”, Jirou stepped closer to the bed again. “He wasn’t supposed to tag along because the structure of the rubble was

already unstable enough, but after he kept following them Aizawa sensei let him go with them. We think he… kind of knew that Kami's quirk could be useful, you know? In case…"

An awkward pause.

"Anyway. Just after they got to you, your heart stopped. Kaminari followed the paramedics' instructions and shocked you back to life. I wasn't there, but everyone said it was pretty… graphic. When the building – uh...", she swallowed, hesitant. "The, the structure was very compromised and it fell, but you all… got out… safely".

Katsuki nodded solemnly. He tried to imagine what it would feel like to need to climb up Deku's chest and shock him back to life, and felt nauseous. Kaminari's situation must have been so much worse than his.

"He was pretty shaken up", Jirou continued, serious. "I mean, we all were. Sero probably told you that yesterday. But, with Kami… It… It was hard for him".

Katsuki looked at her.

"I know".

Jirou nodded.

"He's probably embarrassed he cried in front of you. He kept telling me that he wouldn't cry, but after what he had to do…"

Katsuki scoffed.

"I'll just pretend I forgot about it because of the drugs", he promised.

Jirou smirked.

"How nice of you".

He rolled his eyes.

"What, you prefer I shove it on his face?"

Jirou studied him with a fond look. He had been expecting her to offer a sassy retort, but it never came.

"I'll send him back in", she announced simply, reaching for his shoulder and squeezing it gently. "He'll want to talk to you before we head back home. You take care of yourself, all right? Don't do anything stupid", she advised before stepping away.

This time, she reached the doorknob and twisted it before Katsuki called her again.

"Oi, Ears?"

She turned to look at him.

“Yeah?”

Katsuki hesitated.

“Can you… Can you tell Deku…”

He swallowed dry, not sure how to finish that sentence.

Tell Deku what? What *did* he want to say? That he was sorry he was in deep shit? That he needed to visit him eventually so that Katsuki could return One For All? That he hadn’t meant to make him worried? That he was sorry those assholes wouldn’t let him visit him? Why did he even ask Jirou to do that in the first place?

Jirou smiled softly at him, not waiting for him to continue, as if she knew exactly what he needed to say.

“I’ll tell him”.

Before Katsuki could ask her what she meant, she was gone.

He barely had the time to compute her absence before Kaminari was barging into the room again. The boy marched straight back towards Katsuki’s bed without a word and threw himself atop his friend, enveloping him in a careful yet heartfelt hug.

“*Ouch*”, Katsuki said in spite of himself, because no one had touched more than his shoulder ever since he woke up and having so much weight and pressure on his torso, no matter how careful Kaminari was being, sent pain across his whole body, especially now that the medication had run out.

Kaminari immediately let go of him at him at his protest, eyes still wet and red and face still blotted. He sniffed, taking a step back and cleaning his nose with the back of his hand. Katsuki noticed for the first time the absolution of how disheveled Kaminari looked.

“Sorry”, Kaminari swallowed, clearly awkward. “I didn’t mean to hurt you. I just – I wanted – I really wanted to do that”, he admitted.

Katsuki wanted to scold at him or to give him a mean response, but, again, he could understand where this was coming from. He had already admitted Kaminari’s experience was way worse than his own.

“I know, dumbass”, he grumbled, shifting painfully on the bed. “Just – tell me before you do something”.

Kaminari’s face sparkled.

“You sound better”, he commented. “I mean – you’re no longer slurring so much”.

“It’s ‘cause the meds are running out”, Katsuki scoffed, trying to find a more comfortable position on the bed. Kaminari’s face fell.

“Oh, no. Do you need me to call –“

“*Don’t* – call the nurse”, Katsuki stopped him with a glare, breathing heavily. The pain was becoming more intense with each breath he took, but he knew he needed to talk things out with Kaminari before they sent him back to dreamland. “Let’s talk first”.

Kaminari frowned, embarrassed.

“Uh, talk? About what?”, he asked, sounding and looking way more nervous than necessary.

Katsuki studied his face with suspicion. Why the hell was Kaminari blushing?

“You tell me”, he narrowed his eyes. “You’re the one who came back here”.

Kaminari’s blush deepened, but relief seemed to overcome his tense shoulders.

“Oh”, he sighed, posture slumping a bit. “Oh, I just wanted to see you again before we left. You know. Make sure you’re – doing fine, and all that”.

Katsuki frowned.

“Why’re you so nervous?”, he couldn’t help but to ask, but his tone came off a bit too aggressive. Kaminari’s eyes widened slightly and he tensed up again.

“I’m not”, he said, a bit too defensive. “I’m ok. I’m – I mean. I’m definitely ok, now that I’ve seen you. Jirou must have told you we were all pretty worried”.

Katsuki continued to eye him with suspicion, but nodded, relaxing a bit against the pillows.

“Yeah. I know”.

Kaminari nodded back.

An awkward silence fell upon the room. Kaminari kept looking at him with expectance, as if he was waiting for Katsuki to say something.

“Well?”, he asked.

“Well what?”, Kaminari asked back. Something about his behavior seemed off, but Katsuki couldn’t quite pinpoint it.

He sighed, a bit annoyed, but trying his best to be comprehensive. After closing his eyes for a brief moment in an attempt to gather up patience, he met his friend’s eyes again.

“I don’t know what you want me to say”, Katsuki explained. “I don’t want you to freak out again”.

A bit of the awkwardness in Kaminari’s face disappeared, giving place to a fresh wave of sorrow.

“Sorry about that”, he said, lowering his head a bit. “I – I didn’t mean to do that. I had promised myself I wouldn’t do that, but… It’s like you said”, he sighed, meeting Katsuki’s eyes again. He looked like a kicked puppy. “You know how it is”.

Katsuki felt a bit guilty for being annoyed at Kaminari. Yeah, he did know how it was.

“Yeah”, Katsuki nodded. “But it gets better”.

Kaminari looked away.

“It’s just –“, he continued a bit more quietly. “I was scared. It sucks to admit it because I’m training to be a hero, damn it, I’m not supposed to be scared in a battlefield, but…”

He bit his lower lip.

“You’re my friend”, he shrugged.

Katsuki just stared at him.

Kaminari chuckled, as if that was exactly the sort of response he was expecting.

“And I didn’t want to lose you”, he completed with another shrug, clearly embarrassed and not meeting Katsuki’s eyes. Kaminari looked like he was about to start weeping, face still a bit red, but he held his ground and maintained his composure. “There were so many things that could have gone wrong, I could have ended up killing you if I used too much power, but I could also kill you if I used too little, and even after it worked, I…"

Kaminari trailed off, and Katsuki continued to stare at him. He remembered all those times he was mean to Kaminari, or dismissive, or cold, or aggressive. He remembered all those times he acted like a shitty person and a shitty friend, even if Kaminari knew how to get to his nerves.

He remembered all the times Kaminari was a nice friend, no matter how harshly Katsuki treated him or how mean he was. He remembered Kaminari had an incredible quirk, and could only imagine the level of mastery it must have taken to defibrillate someone.

He remembered Kaminari’s blood-covered face, staring down at him with despair in his eyes.

“Oi, Dunce Face”, he called when it became evident Kaminari was nowhere close to facing him voluntarily.

Kaminari locked eyes with him, uncertain.

“You’re my friend, too”, Katsuki continued, because he knew what Kaminari felt like and he knew what he needed to hear to feel at least a little bit better. “And thanks for saving my life or whatever”.

Kaminari stared at him with a blank expression before his lips stretched into a wide, bright smile.

“Ahh, Kacchan!”, he cheered, diving for another hug. This time, he was extra careful, only enveloping Katsuki’s shoulders and head, but it was still a bit too much for him.

(Especially because of that nickname.)

“Ok, off, *off*”, Katsuki commanded after a short while, ignoring the new stab of pain that coursed through his side as he tried to wriggle himself away from Kaminari’s hold. “Let’s agree it’s too early for us to get all touchy”.

“Yeah, I suppose it takes around 15 years in order to finally get touching clearance with you, right?”, Kaminari chuckled, but Katsuki frowned.

What the hell did he mean by that?

“What?”, he asked, confused.

Kaminari seemed uncomfortable out of a sudden, as if what he said had just backfired on him. He blushed again and looked away.

“Do you…”, he swallowed. “Do you remember anything? After the building fell?”, he asked, scratching the back of his head.

Katsuki frowned.

“Just flashes”, he admitted. “Why?”

Kaminari’s whole posture sagged in relief, a smile dawning on his face.

“Uh… Nothing! Nothing. What I said, uh… It was just a… joke?”, he tried. His tone was lighthearted, but Katsuki could tell there was something off about the “joke”. Especially because of the question Kaminari asked him before claiming that.

“Ain’t jokes supposed to be funny?”, Katsuki asked, suspicious. Kaminari gave him a nervous look and took a step away from the bed.

“Well, it was a poor choice of – of words”, he tried to defend himself.

Katsuki wanted to protest and tell the asshole to just speak his damn mind, but before he could, he grimaced in pain at a new stab at his side. Goddamn impalement injury. Goddamn slow recovery.

“Hey, you… You ok there?” Kaminari approached him again, frowning in concern. “Are you in pain?”

Katsuki gritted his teeth. He didn’t want to have to admit it aloud. If this was Jirou, she would already be calling the nurses without him having to say a word, but since this was Dunce Face… Katsuki would have no such luck.

“I’m fine”, he groaned, jaw locked. “Just the painkillers wearin’ off”.

“Oh”, Kaminari said. “Oh, ok, I’ve got you. I’m about to head out anyway, and you need to rest. I’ll go call the nurse”.

“You don’t have to”, Katsuki protested.

“I think I do –“

“No, you don’t have to go out”, Katsuki rolled his eyes. “You can j’st press the buzzer”.

Kaminari blinked at him.

“Oh”, he blushed. “Ok”, he said, reaching out for the buzzer and pressing it.

Katsuki knew that as soon as he received his new dose, we would get even more groggy and slow, until he fell asleep unexpectedly. That meant he only had a few moments left with Kaminari.

“Are m’ parents still here?”, he asked through gritted teeth, choosing not to comment on the way Kaminari was holding his shoulder in an attempt to offer comfort.

“Uh, I think so, yeah”, Kaminari nodded. “They only let three people in at the same time, so they have to leave for us to visit you. They’ll probably come in after I leave and stay until visiting hours are over”.

Katsuki groaned and nodded in acknowledgement.

“What about Aizawa sensei and All Might?”, he asked, at the same time a nurse rushed into the room.

“Time for your meds, right, dear?”, she offered sweetly, which made Katsuki pissed. He hated the fake gentleness in those nurses’ tones. He was too uncomfortable to make a snarky comment on that, though, so he simply nodded and tried his best to relax against the pillows.

“I haven’t seen them around”, Kaminari answered his question while the nurse fiddled with his IV. “At least not since the investigation thing was declared over”.

“There you go”, the nurse said, offering him a smile. “Don’t worry, dear. You were in two very complicated surgeries. It’s normal for you to be in pain, but soon enough it will be over, ok? You’re healing well”.

For some reason, that made Katsuki feel a tiny bit better. It took him a while to understand why.

The only reason why he didn’t come here yet is because the medical staff wants you to get better before he sees you.

Pff. That was stupid.

“Call again if you need anything, all right?”, the nurse offered him, but before he could even respond – which he wasn’t really planning to do –, she turned to Kaminari. “He’s about to

start feeling pretty groggy, so maybe you should let him rest for a bit".

Kaminari nodded politely, bowing.

"Thank you, miss".

"You're welcome, dear", she bowed back.

And with that, she was gone from the room.

Kaminari stepped closer to him again, studying his face. Katsuki wasn't feeling the effect of his new round of meds just yet, but he did feel tired. No matter how much he hated it.

"How is it?", Kaminari asked him, curious and worried.

"Hasn't kicked in yet", Katsuki huffed, closing his eyes. "Takes a while".

"Hm", Kaminari hummed. "I think… I'd better get going, then. It was nice seeing you, Bakubro".

Katsuki groaned.

"Told ya not to call me that".

"Well", Kaminari shrugged. "Old habits die hard".

Like me, he thought with a scoff. His eyes drooped closed out of their own volition.

"But really", Kaminari added awkwardly. Katsuki reopened his eyes to look at him. "I'm glad I got to talk to you".

Katsuki gave him an amused huff as a response.

"I'm also glad to see this near-death experience didn't make you less grumpy at all", he added with a smirk. "Nice to see you haven't changed, man".

"Shut up", Katsuki rolled his eyes, but there was the hint of a smirk on his face as well.

Kaminari remained by his side, even though he had announced his intention to leave. When he didn't move for a while, Katsuki looked at him again.

"What're you still doin' here?", he asked, his jesting coming off a bit too abrupt.

Kaminari hesitated, not taking offense in his words or his tone.

"Why did you ask about Aizawa sensei?", he questioned eventually, curious.

Katsuki rolled his eyes as a way to hide his discomfort. Truth was, he was well aware his last encounter with the teacher hadn't gone all that well, and he didn't want things to be awkward between him and Aizawa sensei because of the nightmare thing. Or better: he didn't want Aizawa sensei to think he was fucked up in the head or something like that.

But he couldn't let Kaminari know that. He wasn't even sure Kaminari knew about the nightmare, and, if he didn't, explaining the whole thing would only make things more awkward.

"I wan'ed to talk t' him", Katsuki said, hating how quick his tongue was starting to become sluggish. "Bu' I don' wan' an'more visitors", he ended up adding, and only realized the truth behind the words once they were pronounced aloud.

Kaminari frowned at him.

"No more visitors?", he asked for confirmation.

"No' whil' I'm like th's", Katsuki sighed, eyes closing. "J'st m' parents. And sensei. 't least 'til I'm back at UA".

Katsuki couldn't see Kaminari's reaction, since his eyes were closed, but he could practically sense the worry emanating from him.

"… Not even Midoriya?", he asked, voice quiet.

Katsuki huffed.

"Y' said he'll only b' allowed in when 'm well", Katsuki pointed out. Or had it been Jirou who said that? He could no longer remember.

"Well, yeah", Kaminari shrugged. "But that's just because they're afraid you'll end up fighting and you'll make yourself worse. Or that seeing you while you're still unwell will make Midoriya freak out".

Katsuki frowned. That made a bit of sense, and he definitely didn't want Deku to see him all drugged up and weak. He didn't want his other friends to see him like that, either, but he didn't really have a say on it, did he.

He did now.

At the same time he didn't want Deku to see him… *He* wanted to see Deku. He didn't know why that desire was so strong within him, or why it only ever appeared when he was high. But it was there, now. He could feel it. A longing, of sorts. A sentiment difficult to explain or to describe, a melancholic longing that burned deep within him, like a part of him was missing. He remembered seeing a word once, an untranslatable word that described exactly what he felt but couldn't explain.

Saudade.

"Hey, dude", Kaminari called from beside him, and Katsuki realized he was almost gone, almost falling asleep again. "You still awake?"

He wouldn't last long. He wouldn't… He was about to fall asleep. And he needed to see someone…

“J’st tell Aizawa sensei ‘m sorry”, he mumbled.

“For what?!”, Kaminari asked, sounding exasperated and surprised.

Katsuki decided to give into sleep instead of putting an effort on explaining.

When he woke up again, it was night. There was no one there with him.

Katsuki sighed, throwing his head back against the pillows. He made a quick assessment of his pain, and found that his side wasn’t aching so bad. Maybe it was the painkillers, maybe he was finally healing. Whatever was the answer to that question, he decided he wasn’t about to complain.

He still felt so tired, though. And thirsty.

He had been thirsty back at his friends’ visit, but while he was a little less worried about his pride, he still valued it enough to not want his friends to feed him ice chips. Just the thought of it was mortifying.

Also, he had just woken up after what must have been hours of sleep, and yet he still felt like he was ready for more. Ready to indulge into that blissful blackness and just forget about his pain and the state he was in for a while. That wasn’t characteristic of him, but maybe the meds were sending him beyond the point of caring.

He couldn’t help but to find himself staring at the closed door of his room, longing. From the glass wall, he could see a couple nurses working the night shift, and the overall very calm hospital floor. Soft dark-blue lights sent the whole place into a calm, peaceful hue, but Katsuki didn’t want blue. He wanted green.

Now that he was a bit more sober and a bit less in pain, he could understand why Deku hadn’t visited him yet. Well, he could try. First, he hadn’t been allowed to because of the investigation, and then, once that was over, he wasn’t allowed to because of the fact that every single person who knew them also knew how prone they were to get into fights with each other. And to be very honest, for the first time in his whole life – Katsuki didn’t feel like getting into a fight. Most of all, he didn’t feel like getting into a fight with Deku.

He sighed. He hated that he was too tired to feel pissed at himself for his own lethargy.

Maybe he'd feel a bit more like himself once he was off these meds and off this shitty bed. Truth be told, he couldn't wait to go back to his normal routine and go on about his life and his dream of building a fantastic career.

He had a feeling that wouldn't happen, though.

Not the career thing. He had determined that, since the whole strangling thing had been a dream, the part where he lost his quirk was also coming from his imagination. He couldn't really use his quirk and prove it, since his arms were still enveloped in casts and bandages, but he was fairly sure that his quirk was ok and that the nightmare was just a reflex of his panicked brain. No, he meant the going-back-to-his-normal-routine thing.

It was evident the nurses who visited were being very reticent about his state. He hadn't even met his doctor, which was weird as fuck, considering the fact that he was here for what, over a week now? Someone other than his parents or teachers or friends should have stepped in to explain his condition.

Suddenly, a spike of anxiety hit him. Why hadn't his doctor shown up? What were they hiding from him?

Was he still dying? Nah. Despite the excruciating pain he still felt sometimes, the tiredness and the sluggishness, he didn't feel like he was dying. He wasn't sure how he knew that, because he couldn't remember what dying felt like, but he just… knew.

So what, then? Were there complications to his health? Was he incapacitated in some way? Would his recovery last longer than he had anticipated?

… Would he ever make a full recovery?

Maybe he wouldn't. Maybe that was why Recovery Girl hadn't shown up to heal his arms yet. Maybe that was the real reason they were keeping Deku away. Because they knew that if there was *one thing* the fucker was incapable of doing, that thing was keeping a secret from him. Katsuki might have spent a good deal of his life hating the guy's guts, but even back then, he knew as much. Hell, Deku had been chosen as All Might's fucking *heir* and he hadn't been able to keep that from Katsuki.

Fuck. That was it, wasn't it? This injury or whatever had been way too serious and he wouldn't be able to become a hero. And maybe his quirk *really* was gone, and his brain hadn't been playing tricks on him – it had been *letting him know.* He was being compared to All Might before his career had even begun, and he would already be forgotten before he could even graduate. His life-long dream would go down the drain because some idiots with a grudge had to kidnap a bunch of people and have a bomb with them. God *damn* it.

Katsuki didn't care how heroic people thought he was. How great, how amazing, how astounding. All he cared about was the fact there was something wrong, something terrible about to happen to his future, and all he could do was lie in a hospital bed all alone, too incapacitated to even press the buzzer and call a damn nurse for help because both his arms were being held in *casts*.

He wished at least Aizawa was there. Or maybe even All Might – he would take what he could fucking get, really. The one he really wanted was Deku, but they couldn't see each other yet. If anything, Katsuki didn't want Deku to see him like that, all weak and casted-up in a bed, unable to even take a piss by himself – unable to – to breathe.

He couldn't breathe. There was nothing blocking his airway, but the panic was making him hyperventilate. He was losing it. There was something wrong with his quirk. There was something wrong with his body. Something terrible was about to happen, someone was about to give him terrible news, his future was about to change and be stripped away from him –

Suddenly the door to his room opened, and Katsuki's heart made another leap. Aizawa was rushing towards him, which was suspicious as fuck since he had just *wished* for the man to be there. Was this another figment of his imagination?

Maybe it was. Maybe it was a hallucination. Maybe this was a villain who could read minds, or who could sense a person's wish. Maybe this was an invader. Why the fuck would his teacher be there in the middle of the night? How convenient was that? How suspicious was that? And he couldn't even defend himself –

Aizawa marched towards him, sitting at the edge of his bed but being very careful not to touch him. And what the hell would he do to him? Would he sedate him, so he could fulfil his evil doppelganger goals? Would he kill him? He would kill him, right? That was what this Eraserhead double was going to do. He would kill Katsuki, and *then* his hero career would be over for good, terminated before it had even started, and ending with him in All Might's shadow –

"Bakugou", Aizawa called, serious. "You have to *breathe*".

It felt like emerging from deep water. Suddenly, the frantic beeping of his own heart monitor flooded his impaired ears. It didn't take him too long to notice the erratic, rushed pattern of his breathing again, which was coming out as deaf puffs. His heart was beating so fast inside his chest it felt like it was about to burst out of his ribcage; black spots were dancing in front of his eyes.

"Breathe, Katsuki", Aizawa instructed again, uncharacteristically urgent.

Katsuki's moist eyes found his teacher's, and even if they looked sincerely worried, Katsuki still didn't buy it.

"Sir –", a voice came from the door, and Katsuki's eyes frantically searched the room until he found a hesitating nurse by the doorstep. She looked like she needed to come in, but Aizawa held an authoritative hand stretched out towards her, silently telling her to stay where she was.

"You'll make it worse", Aizawa said, eyes still fixed on the hyperventilating Katsuki. "It's a panic attack. I've got this".

It's not a panic attack he's trying to poison me and kill me can't you see you idiot just march in here and drag him away from me before I die for good –

“Ok”, the nurse nodded, and *no no no what the fuck are you doing come back*, “But I’ll be back in a few to make sure he’s all right”.

Katsuki squeezed his eyes shut, feeling – with shame and mortification – as hot tears popped out his closed eyes and slid down his temples. He needed to get out of this. He couldn’t defend himself. Maybe if he set off an explosion, even with a broken arm, it would tear the cast apart and give him back his mobility – but what if his quirk was gone for good – what then –

“Bakugou”, Aizawa called. “Look at me”.

Katsuki didn’t want to. But if he kept this up, he would pass out, and *then* he would be completely defenseless and at this guy’s mercy. He tried holding his breath for a moment before sucking in another a lungful of air. Then he did it again – held his breath, breathed out, breathed in. Held his breath, breathed out, breathed in.

And again. And again. And again.

Nothing happened. Aizawa didn’t kill him, no one attacked him, he wasn’t suddenly murdered by an impostor. The only thing that changed was that he could breathe again, and that was good.

Slowly, he reopened his eyes, finding his teacher’s concerned gaze still glued to him. His breaths were still coming out as panting, but he could see more clearly now – and think more clearly, too.

“It’s ok”, Aizawa said, and even though his words were comforting, his tone was still somehow strict – maybe this was a result of years of teaching a bunch of annoying teenagers. “It’s just me here with you. I’m not going to hurt you. I’m your teacher. I’m here to help”.

Despite hating being treated like a child or a lunatic, Katsuki’s shoulders relaxed the tiniest bit. But his glistening eyes probably betrayed the suspicion he still felt. Noticing this, Aizawa sighed.

“Kaminari gave me your message”, he explained, and ok, that was a bit of a proof that this was actually his teacher. Katsuki relaxed a bit more, but not completely.

An eternity of silence seemed to pass after that, with Katsuki breathing erratically until the pattern started to go back to normal and Aizawa sitting there by his side without ever touching him, as if he was sure the boy would start to panic if they as much as bumped accidentally. Once Katsuki’s heart monitor went back to registering an acceptable pace, Aizawa finally relaxed, standing up from the bed but remaining by Katsuki’s side.

Katsuki refused to meet his teacher’s eyes, too embarrassed by the fact that this was the second breakdown the man had witnessed. What kind of image was he giving off to the man who was supposed to give him his hero license and diploma?

With a sigh, Aizawa walked around the bed and towards the uncomfortable-looking plastic chair by the corner of the room. He grabbed it and dragged it closer to the bed, taking a sit

beside Katsuki like he used to do before the nightmare. The boy continued to stare up at the ceiling, avoiding eye contact.

What a fucking weakling he had become, huh? Was this the person he was, now? Someone who freaked out all the time, who shat themselves because of imaginary threats? Who couldn't tell reality and fantasy apart? What kind of hero would he make, then? What if he hurt a civilian because he thought they were a villain? What if he *didn't* hurt a villain because he thought they were a civilian?

Before all this shit, he was always sure of himself, he always trusted his guts and his ability. He never felt doubt when it came to his own perception. But now? Now he couldn't even tell if his damn teacher was actually his teacher. And he didn't know what the *hell* was happening to him.

Actually, he didn't even know what the hell Aizawa was doing there, in the middle of the goddamn night.

"What are you doing here?", Katsuki asked, feeling more sober than he had felt in days. He was pretty sure his pain meds were up-to-date, but he could, for once, think clearly and rationally, with no fog to confuse his brain.

He could tell Aizawa was looking at him, but he couldn't bring himself to look back, even if the room was majorly dark. The only source of dim illumination was coming from the hall outside, painting the walls dark neon blue.

Aizawa sighed.

"Kaminari gave me your message –"

"You said that", Katsuki interrupted him, rather impolitely. "So you decided to come over in the middle of the night because of that? Tch".

A pause. He finally turned his head to look at his teacher – more out of instinct than anything else.

It was Aizawa who averted his eyes this time, leaning forwards on the chair so that his knees were supporting his elbows. He was gazing at the floor.

"I've been coming over every day, actually. But I usually stay outside".

Katsuki frowned. He hadn't seen that coming.

"What? Why?", he asked, confused and suspicious.

Aizawa sighed again, apparently gathering up courage to address an uncomfortable subject.

"I didn't want to make you feel threatened or unsafe", he admitted, managing to sound as stern as always. "But I'd still rather make sure no one would give you actual reason to feel that way".

Katsuki squinted his eyes. Why would he feel threatened by his damn teacher?

But as soon as that question appeared in his brain, his heart provided the answer. He *had* felt threatened. Not by Aizawa per say, but by the chance that he was someone else posing as him. Or by the chance that he was under some sort of control or manipulation, as had been the case in his dream.

He felt shame rise to his cheeks in the form of a blush as he stared at his teacher's grim face. There wasn't guilt or shame in there – but rather some sort of concern, as if he knew that he was causing Katsuki distress but didn't know how to fix it.

Katsuki didn't know how to fix it, either. He didn't even know why his teacher was causing him to react in that way in the first place.

"It's not – you", he tried to explain.

Aizawa raised his head to stare at him, his face the picture of attention. He still remained as serious as ever, making him look as if they were in the classroom, and as if he was about to evaluate one of Katsuki's mid-term seminars.

"I mean. I know you have no reason to hurt me or whatever", Katsuki continued, feeling a bit embarrassed and out of his depth. He still managed to put on a tough façade, even if he felt exhausted from the so-called 'panic attack' from just moments ago. "But when I had that dream, you were being controlled. By that villain from the expo".

Aizawa just stared at him for a moment, before nodding.

"Did you think I was being controlled when I tried to help you now, too?", he asked, surgical.

Katsuki's jaw tightened. He didn't want to admit this, because he didn't want his teacher, the man who would determine if he could become a hero or not, to think he was a basket case. But something told him that even if he lied, Aizawa would know the truth, and trying to hide it would only make things worse.

"Yeah. Or maybe that you were a double", he admitted, looking away again. "I couldn't tell why you were here in the middle of the damn night", he added a bit angrily, glaring at the ceiling above him. Maybe that would earn him some coherence points.

From the corners of his eyes, he could see Aizawa nod again.

"And does that happen often?"

Katsuki frowned.

"What?"

"This feeling that villains are about to attack you all the time, in the form of someone you know or maybe controlling someone you know".

Katsuki scoffed.

“Tch”, was all he said, all he could say. For some reason, his teacher’s question bothered him – like throwing salt over an open wound.

“Bakugou –“

“I’m not a nutcase”, he snapped, maybe a bit too harshly. Aizawa narrowed his eyes at him, and Katsuki turned his head to face him again. “I’m not fucking crazy, or paranoid, or whatever it is you’re thinking”.

Aizawa stared at him, serious.

“I’m not thinking any of that”, he said simply, calmly. “I just wanted to know”.

Katsuki turned his head again, glaring at the ceiling.

Aizawa sighed, sounding defeated.

A few more moments of silence passed, but Katsuki was too tense to go back to sleep. His pain wasn’t so bad, now, so he couldn’t tell if he was actually healing or if the painkillers were still making him senseless to that. Whatever was the answer, he decided not to think too much about that – lest he freak out in front of his teacher *yet again*, which was the reason Aizawa had to enter his room that night in the first place.

“How’s your pain?”, Aizawa asked, which made Katsuki even more irritated – that was precisely the subject he didn’t want to talk about. But he didn’t have the option of not responding, either. He sighed.

“Better”, he said shortly. “I’m not feeling anything right now”.

Aizawa hummed in understanding.

More silence in the room.

“I want to ask you something”, Aizawa announced after a while, as if asking him things hadn’t been his sole purpose ever since he arrived.

Katsuki turned his head to look at him, saying nothing but indicating he could continue. *Might as well get this over with already.*

“Why did you want Kaminari to tell me you were sorry?”, his teacher asked.

Katsuki blinked at him before turning his head and staring at the ceiling for a few more moments.

“You didn’t visit again after that day”, he admitted. Deep down, he was hating that he was being forced to open up, but he knew that explaining his side of things was better than having his teacher think he was crazy. “So I thought you were, I don’t know. Pissed, or something”.

“Why would I be?”, Aizawa asked, and Katsuki let out a long, exasperated sigh. *So much for one fucking question, eh?*

“What are you, my therapist?”, he snapped angrily. Fine, he wanted to prove his sanity to his teacher, but couldn’t he stop prying for one second and just accept his word? *God*.

Katsuki turned his head again to look at him, hoping he’d get the hint from his expression. It didn’t work, and Aizawa continued to stare at him in expectance for an answer.

“I know I freaked you out because of the nightmare”, Katsuki forced himself to say. “But that’s what it was. Just a nightmare. It’s not a big deal, but since you stopped coming, I thought it had bothered you somehow”.

“But you said ‘I’m sorry’”, Aizawa pointed out. “And that’s not very usual, coming from you”.

“Yeah, so what?”, he huffed.

“So I was worried there was something else behind that apology”.

Silence. Katsuki swallowed dry.

He breathed out hard, hating that his teacher was right.

“I… Know that what happened must have been…”, he said through gritted teeth. “Troublesome”.

Aizawa nodded.

“But I was just trying to help everyone. We couldn’t tell if that Matsuo bastard would get to the police and the pros in time, and they were – they were literally trying to brainwash the whole country. I couldn’t just stand there and do nothing, license or no license”.

Aizawa nodded again.

“I’m aware”.

“But the bomb should have never gone off. I didn’t know there was more. None of us did, and by the time we found out, it was too late. We thought just restraining all of them and waiting for the pros was the best course of action. I was…”, he tightened his jaw in anger. “I was naïve”.

Aizawa didn’t nod this time – he just stared at Katsuki.

More silence fell between them. Once he figured out Aizawa wasn’t about to break it, Katsuki looked away again, not knowing what else to say.

“You know”, his teacher started eventually – as if he had just been waiting for Katsuki to break eye contact before he spoke up. “Everyone was very worried about you”.

Katsuki suppressed the urge to roll his eyes.

“Yeah. That’s all I’ve been hearing, lately”, he admitted, a bit pissed. He was kind of glad to know so many people cared about him despite his tough personality, but frankly – they didn’t need to. He wasn’t some weak-ass damsel in distress, he was strong, for fuck’s sake. Wasn’t the fact that he had survived proof enough of that?

“As a teacher in a hero school, I’m aware of the dangers my students face day-to-day”, the man continued, somber. “But it’s never easy to see them hurt. It’s never easy to see them die”.

Katsuki blinked, still avoiding eye contact.

“You don’t have to apologize for doing what you did. You didn’t have a license, which is… troublesome, like you said. This also isn’t your first time getting into a problematic situation as this. But if you’re worried about expulsion or losing your license, you can rest assured that won’t happen”.

Katsuki risked taking a peek at Aizawa.

“The investigation concluded that this was an uncommon situation, with uncommon circumstances and a bomb threat. Time was of essence, and you had little to no certain means of contacting the pros or the police. Also, eyewitnesses testified that none of you used your quirks as a direct means of hurting or combating the villains, which means that, technically, you didn’t break any laws”.

Katsuki’s shoulders sagged a bit in relief, and only then did he notice they were tense.

Maybe that had been the reason why he couldn’t use his quirk in his dream. His brain had turned his fear of expulsion and loss of career into something metaphorical, such as being unable to use his explosions – which would happen if he didn’t have a license.

“But I have to warn you, Bakugou”, Aizawa continued, tone grimmer. “People don’t like the attention you’ve been getting. First, the kidnapping with the League, then, the incident in the sewers, now, the situation with the expo… There will be eyes on you, more than ever and harsher than ever. And they might not be so lenient if you pull off something like this another time”.

Katsuki’s lips closed to form a thin, stern line. He looked as serious as Aizawa.

“No one enjoys precocious greatness. Not your enemies, not your friends. Greatness means challenge, challenge means conflict. Even though you are training to be a hero, I can guarantee you want to leave the conflict for when you are graduated, employed, and emotionally stable”.

Katsuki suppressed a scoff, frowning instead.

“I can take it”, he protested, and Aizawa shook his head as if that was exactly the answer he had been expecting.

“Yes, I’m aware. I’m also aware you could have died, so maybe stay away from trouble for a while, trouble kid”, he retorted, sounding a bit irritated.

Katsuki swallowed dry, silent and half-scowling.

Aizawa sighed again.

“All I’m saying is”, he continued, sounding more collected. “I won’t always be able to stand up for you. Neither will UA. And if something like this happens again…”, he trailed off for a moment. “There are no guarantees you’ll be able to stay in this path”.

Katsuki’s frown deepened, heart speeding up a bit.

“What are you saying?”

Aizawa stared at him, stern.

“I’m saying that if I were you, I would lay low and keep it to myself for a while. Let people forget about me. Pray that people won’t compare me to All Might at age 17 and that this won’t send more and more villains after me before I even graduate”, he said sharply.

Katsuki frowned. He had never heard Aizawa, the usually “I’m-going-to-speak-in-a-monotone-even-when-I’m-scolding-you” teacher, sound so… sarcastic? Something about it didn’t sit right with him, but before he could freak out about doppelgangers or mind control again, Katsuki found himself asking:

“What is this really about?”

And with that, Aizawa deflated, shoulders sagging and head falling in defeat, as if he was too tired to keep up with that angry-teacher act.

Katsuki stared. It took the man a while to finally respond, and when he did, his head was still hanging low.

“Let’s just say seeing you get buried in rubble and almost die didn’t sit right with me, trouble kid”, he admitted, voice back to the usual monotone.

Katsuki continued to stare at him, but his teacher didn’t move from that mournful position. His voice had sounded normal – it didn’t shake, or tremble, or even falter. But there was something about his tone – something about the way he said those words. It was heavy, and grim.

“Is that…”, Katsuki tried, swallowing dry. He felt uncharacteristically hesitant, especially if this was a personal issue to his teacher, but the words just formed themselves around his tongue out of their own free will. “Is that why you’ve been coming over every night?”

A pregnant pause. Aizawa didn’t move, head still lowered.

“You have potential, Bakugou”, he settled for saying. “A lot of it. Don’t throw it in the trash because you’re in a hurry to be grand. You have to be careful. Greatness will come to you

when it's time, and when you earn it".

Aizawa raised his head to stare at him. There was nothing unnatural about his face – no trace of tears, of sorrow, of emotion. Despite that, for some reason, Katsuki could tell his teacher was grieving.

"Just keep training and improving", Aizawa concluded. "Don't put the cart before the horse".

Katsuki stared at him. Even if he wanted to argue, he had to admit he had hated to know he was being called "the new All Might". Maybe he had hated it for the wrong reasons, but he had hated it anyway. His teacher's suggestion – to lay low after three consecutive disasters that could have resulted in death and tragedy – didn't sound so far off.

Finally, he nodded. Like a student obeying his sensei's orders.

"*Hai*".

Aizawa seemed a bit relieved, even if he didn't look all that convinced. Katsuki watched him with attentive eyes as the man leaned back against the chair's rest, looking like he was ready to spend the rest of the night there.

Even if he was still a bit on the edge… He found that he didn't mind.

"You don't have to stay", he ended up saying anyway, the desire to look strong still etched in his heart. "I'm fine".

Aizawa eyed him.

"I know you are", he nodded, sincere. "But since I'm already here, I might as well. If you don't mind, of course".

Katsuki nodded, looking away.

He felt tired, but he still wasn't ready to sleep. There was something still bothering him. Well, a lot of things, actually, and his mind was too caught up trying to process everything to actually find enough peace to sleep.

His eyes averted to the door, in spite of himself. It was closed, as expected, and he felt stupid for hoping it wouldn't be. It was the middle of the night. And he knew very well the limitations of who could visit him in his deathbed.

Aizawa must have noticed he was gazing at the door, because he said:

"So they told you about Midoriya?"

Katsuki stared at the door for another second before turning his head towards Aizawa again. He had to admit he didn't particularly enjoy how easily his teacher seemed to have figured out what he was thinking.

"What about him?", he asked, defensive.

Aizawa studied his face.

“He’s not allowed to visit you. Not until you’re better, anyway”.

Katsuki scoffed.

“Yeah. I heard”.

“And does that make you angry?”

Katsuki blinked, looking away.

He thought for a while.

“No”, he admitted with sincerity. “But I want to see the nerd”.

Aizawa sighed.

“I was the one who prohibited it. And All Might agreed with the decision, even if Midoriya has been wearing him out over it on a daily basis”.

Katsuki frowned, glaring at his teacher. Aizawa didn’t seem impressed by the sudden change of behavior.

“Are you angry now?”, he asked, curious.

Katsuki scoffed.

“Well, *yeah*”, he admitted.

Aizawa shifted on the chair, trying to find a more comfortable position and looking untroubled by Katsuki’s anger.

“I know how you two are around each other. And you are in no state to see him, not while you’re still recovering. It might set you back”.

Katsuki scoffed again, offended.

“It won’t *set me back*”, he protested. “What, you really think Deku will be insensitive enough to start a fight with me while I’m in a –“

“It’s not him I’m worried about”, Aizawa cut him off. “I know he won’t be the one to start the fight”.

Katsuki narrowed his eyes.

“Why would I fight Deku?”, he asked with disdain.

“Why wouldn’t you?”, Aizawa retorted with ease. “You two are always at each other’s throats when left unsupervised. Actually, even when you *are* supervised –“

“Yeah, but I wouldn’t do it now”, Katsuki interrupted him before he could finish that sentence.

Aizawa stared at him, skepticism evident in his tired eyes.

“And why is that?”

“Tch. Because I can’t wait to get the hell away from this hospital”, Katsuki retorted. “And fighting Deku will only make me stay here longer”.

“If that is the case, then you can wait a while longer before you see him”, Aizawa shrugged simply. “Recovery Girl is coming over in a few days to heal your arms, and then you’ll be transferred back to UA. There, you can talk to Midoriya”.

Katsuki’s mouth opened and closed. He hadn’t seen that coming.

“You’ll still have to stay at UA’s medbay for a while, for observation”, Aizawa concluded. “Recovery Girl managed to heal the worst of it, but you’re still recovering from your injury. It might take a while. But once you’re back in school grounds, I’ll allow you two to talk”.

Katsuki stared at his teacher. Now that he knew how long it would be before he could see and talk to Deku, it felt stupid – and perhaps even childish – to keep insisting on the matter. He didn’t know why the lack of Deku by his bedside had bothered him so much, or why he was so eager to see the nerd, but the promise that he would be able to talk to him on just a few days was… well. It was something.

“If it’s any consolation, he’s as desperate to see you as you are desperate to see him”, Aizawa concluded.

Katsuki felt the blood rising to his cheeks, and clicked his tongue.

“I’m not desperate to see him”, he protested, but the words were halfhearted even to his own ears.

Aizawa simply directed him a look that was full of skepticism. Katsuki rolled his eyes, knowing it wouldn’t be useful to argue.

“Did Kaminari tell you everything?”

“Hm?”

“About me not wanting visitors until I’m back at UA”.

Aizawa stared at him.

“He did. Consider your request done”.

Katsuki blinked.

“Really?”

“Well, yes”, Aizawa said simply. “There’s no reason to force you to take visitors when you don’t want them. The priority here is your recovery. The only ones allowed in will be your parents, me, and All Might, if that’s ok”.

Katsuki thought for a moment.

“Yeah. That’s ok”.

(Katsuki was glad he didn’t have to argue more for his request to be accepted. He was pretty sure that ‘I keep hoping that Deku is here whenever someone visits and finding that he isn’t pisses me off’ wouldn’t count as a proper excuse).

Aizawa nodded.

“You should get some rest, now”, he advised.

His tone was dismissive and left no space for an argument. Maybe he had read the tiredness that was etched in Katsuki’s face, even if he was still too frantic to sleep – maybe he, himself, was too tired, and wanted Katsuki to give him a rest. Whatever the answer was, Katsuki decided to comply, but not before he addressed one last thing that was bothering him.

“… Sensei?”, he asked.

“Yes?”, Aizawa responded.

Katsuki swallowed dry.

“It wasn’t just about me, was it?”, he asked.

Aizawa stared at him, confused.

“You said that seeing me almost die buried beneath rubble didn’t sit right with you”, he explained. “But I don’t think it was just about me”.

Aizawa looked away, a flash of anger crossing his eyes before they went back to looking impassive. He seemed very uncomfortable, out of a sudden. Katsuki was nearly regretting the unusual prying, but then his teacher answered.

“I lost someone like that”, Aizawa admitted. “Someone dear to me. I had promised myself never to let it happen again, and I almost failed”.

Katsuki stared at him, trying to figure out what to say. It was no surprise that he sucked at comforting people, but, for some strange reason, he could empathize with his teacher, in a similar way to how he had empathized with Kaminari. He knew what it felt like, to lose someone close. Someone… Someone… *dear*. The feeling of empathy was one completely alien to him, but he… He knew how much these situations sucked.

“I’m sorry”, he settled for saying, even if the words sounded forced and alien, coming from his mouth.

Aizawa gave him a weird look, as if he was thinking exactly that.

“I know”, Katsuki said before his teacher could comment. “But I… Didn’t mean to put you in that position. And I survived, so you don’t have to worry anymore”.

Aizawa snorted, the tiny – and frankly creepy – hint of a smirk appearing on his lips.

“I’ll always worry about my students”.

Katsuki rolled his eyes. That was cheesy.

“Yeah, but what I mean is, you don’t have to keep coming over during the night or something. I’ll be ok”.

Aizawa gave him another uncomfortable look, before staring at the distance.

“I’d rather be safe than sorry”, he said, rather grimly.

Katsuki frowned. Something told him there was something else behind that story, something darker. But he knew better than to keep prying, especially because of the way Aizawa’s eyes looked.

Instead, he turned his head away again, ready to go back to sleep. A soft knock echoed in the door, and soon enough a nurse was pushing it open just a bit, poking her head inside and taking a glimpse at Katsuki and Aizawa. With a nod from the man, she came in, ready to check on Katsuki after his freak out.

She asked him a couple questions about how he was faring up, if he needed anything, yadda, yadda, yadda, but he only answered the basic and made sure to let her know he was ok. With a satisfied nod from her and a final check of the equipment attached to him, she left, leaving Katsuki alone with his teacher once again.

“I can stay outside, if you want”, Aizawa offered.

Katsuki didn’t look at him.

“It’s ok. I mean, you can leave, if you want”.

“I’m not leaving”.

Katsuki sighed.

“Then you can stay here. I won’t freak out again”.

It was Aizawa’s turn to sigh.

“That wasn’t a freak out, Bakugou. It was a –“

“Don’t say it”.

A pause.

“It was a panic attack”, Aizawa finished anyway. “And trust me, they’re more common amongst heroes than you’d think”.

Katsuki eyed him.

“Do you have them?”, he ended up asking, despite feeling like the question was crossing a line.

Aizawa hesitated, but his eyes didn’t leave Katsuki’s.

“Sometimes”.

Katsuki swallowed.

“And what do you do?”

Aizawa continued to stare at him deeply.

“I try to ground myself. Find out what might be causing it, even if sometimes, there is no trigger. Control my breathing. Sensory recalibration. I’m sure your therapist will know something that can help you specifically. It works differently with everyone. But it’s no reason for shame”.

Katsuki scoffed with a bit of incredulity, breaking eye contact and looking away.

“It isn’t”, Aizawa insisted. “It’s a sign there’s still humanity in you, despite everything you might have gone through”.

Yeah, pretty words. Katsuki wasn’t so sure he wanted there to be any sort of humanity inside him, though, not when it made him feel like he was drowning and having a heart attack, all at the same time. For what felt like the thousandth time, he wished he could go back to feeling just one emotion.

It wasn’t like he had been happier back then, but at least he didn’t have to deal with panic attacks that made his face numb and his heart race.

But then he thought back at the secret feeling of belonging when he saw his surprise birthday party, of the warm feeling that blossomed in his chest whenever Deku praised him or laughed at something he said. He thought of his mom caressing his hair, and of Inko’s warm hugs. His dad’s comprehension, Aizawa’s unyielding faith in his potential, Jirou’s playlists, Mina’s photos, Kirishima’s fist bumps, Kaminari and Sero’s teasing.

He thought of the feeling of Deku hugging him.

He thought of the fear he had felt when he saw the bombs in the auditorium. He thought of how that fear had sent his brain into crisis-averter mode, allowing him to think quickly enough in order to save everybody else’s lives. His anger had saved Japan from mind-control, that was true, but his fear had saved his friends' lives.

He wasn’t so sure he would have succeeded if all this had happened a year before.

So yeah, maybe being a bit more human wasn't so bad. Maybe… Maybe it could even help his career.

He only wished it didn't hurt so much.

He ended up drifting off, falling into an easier sleep now that he knew there was someone he trusted watching over him. For once, feeling embarrassed or weak because of it didn't even cross his mind.

When Katsuki woke up, Aizawa was gone. It was morning, and he was alone again.

Izuku remembered.

Kacchan's head lolled to the side and his whole body went limp, and yet Izuku could still feel the warmth of his lips against his, the tingling of his tongue against his own.

Kacchan had kissed him. Kacchan had *kissed him*.

His heart was beating so fast inside his chest that there was no space for air inside his lungs. He couldn't breathe. Because Kacchan – Kacchan had – had kissed him, why would he do that, why did he do that, and now he had passed out again and his face was paler than ever and shit, crap, Izuku's hands were no longer pressing on his injury and blood was flowing out, freely, like a river, pooling sickly beneath his knees and soaking through the fabric of his clothes.

What was happening, oh god. Kacchan had – why would – he – he had – and now he was – he –

“Midoriya…?”, a familiar voice asked from afar, and Izuku’s spirit nearly jumped out of his body (again) as he snapped his head to find Kaminari staring at him, at the bottom of the opening to the pocket, eyes wide and face pale.

It only took one quick look at Kaminari’s face to realize it.

He had seen it. He had seen the kiss.

If that was even possible, Izuku’s heart rate doubled in pace. All his blood drained from his face and went to his twisting stomach, but before he could even think of stuttering out a response, Aizawa sensei appeared out of nowhere with Uraraka and three paramedics. They were carrying very little equipment, probably in order to prevent a rubble collapse.

Izuku blinked at them, mouth opening and closing, heart and head racing too much for him to form coherent words. His face and hands felt numb, and then he remembered Kacchan was still bleeding out, and his hands acted before he could think about it. He went back to pressing down on the injury, but he was shaking from head to toe. He didn’t know what to do. He didn’t know what was happening.

“You can leave it to us”, the first paramedic to approach him said, gently but urgently. Izuku simply stared at her, eyes wide and bloodied face pale, not able to comprehend what she was telling him.

The other two paramedics approached him too, but he was frozen in place. They were talking to him, he knew, but their words just passed through his brain as if they were in a different language altogether.

Aizawa’s hand gripped his shoulder and Izuku turned to look at him, but he was still in shock. He had no idea what he was being told, or what they wanted him to do. All he knew was that Kacchan had kissed him, and that if he didn’t keep applying pressure to his injury he would bleed out.

Then, something finally broke him away from his trance.

“We’re losing him!”, one of the paramedics shouted.

Izuku didn’t compute Uraraka’s shocked gasp, or Kaminari’s desperate shout of “no!”, or the paramedics’ many curses. All he could see was Kacchan’s pale, unconscious face – all he could hear was his own heart, beating frantically inside his chest.

Then, everything became as clear as water.

Kacchan hated him. Well, maybe he didn’t *hate* him anymore, they had been over that several times over. But he had, undeniably, spent the majority of his life hating Izuku. Now he cared about him, fine, ok, but one doesn’t go from hate to – to caring, to kissing, in so little time. And Kacchan was smart, he had always had a quick thinking, so there had to be a greater reason behind that kiss. A strategical reason.

And there was only one he could think of.

Izuku reached out for a force deep within him, feeling dread as One For All manifested itself in the form of green static across his skin. He didn't know how the transfer had happened so quickly, but he did know that a transfer through saliva was probably faster than a transfer through hair. His stomach twisted with nausea, dread, and rage as soon as the lightning died down.

Kacchan had passed One For All back to him. He had sensed he was dying, and he had passed Izuku's quirk back to him.

He had given up.

"You bastard", Izuku roared, voice uncharacteristically raw. He pressed down harder on Kacchan's side, ignoring the pair of hands trying to pull him away from the boy, because like *hell* he would allow Kacchan to give up now. "You son of a – don't you *dare* do this!", he yelled. "You hear me? Don't you dare give up, you idiot!"

"Midoriya, stop!", Aizawa ordered from behind him, and then Izuku realized he was the one trying to pull him away. He shrugged away from the teacher's grasp and threw himself over Kacchan defensively, attempting to stanch the blood flow before it was too late.

"Deku-kun, step away!", Uraraka pleaded, hands covering her mouth. There were tears running down her pink cheeks, a horrified expression etched on her face.

"Kacchan! Are you listening to me? Do not do this!", he screamed, guttural, struggling as Aizawa grabbed hold of him again and pulled.

"Midoriya, step away *now*. There's no time for this", he ordered, angry.

"Midoriya…", even Kaminari tried, still looking shocked by what he had witnessed. The paramedics tried their best to ignore Izuku's desperate fussing and started to tend to Kacchan's injury, removing the remaining rubble that was covering his lower half and assessing if there were any more injuries that required immediate treatment.

"Kacchan!", Izuku screamed as his teacher finally succeeded in dragging him away. Izuku was drenched in Kacchan's blood – his hands, arms, face, and knees were painted a deep crimson. His limbs flailed desperately as he tried to break free from Aizawa's hold, but it was useless – the man was stronger than he was.

"Deku-kun –", Uraraka tried to ease him, but it was to no avail. Izuku ignored her.

"Kacchan!", he screamed, guttural, tears rolling down his face. "Kacchaaaaaan!"

"Step away now, Midoriya", Aizawa said to his ear. "You'll only get in their way".

"Hey, you're the one with the gravity quirk, right?", one of the paramedics asked urgently, looking at Uraraka. She nodded promptly, leaving Izuku's side and approaching them hesitantly. Kaminari took her place, trying to aid Aizawa into holding Izuku down.

"You need to make this piece of rubble float, now", another paramedic instructed. "We need to get him help as soon as possible".

“Wait, wait, wait”, the third paramedic said, his voice urgent and worried. “He stopped breathing”.

“Kacchan”, Izuku sobbed, sagging desperately against Aizawa.

“What do I do?!”, Uraraka asked, nervous, not knowing if they still wanted her to move the rubble.

“Miss, stay back”, the first paramedic instructed. She climbed on top of Kacchan, minding the piece of metal sticking out of him, and started CPR. “You, start the transfusion”.

“*Here*?”, the third paramedic asked – he seemed to be the youngest one.

“There’s no time, he’s lost too much blood, he’ll bleed out before we take him out of here and climb all the way down! Do it now!”

Without further ado, the second paramedic jumped into action.

“You, keep applying pressure to that!”, she ordered the third one.

Izuku could not see what they were doing from where he was sprawled on the floor, Aizawa immobilizing him in a tight grip. Kaminari was holding his legs, but his eyes were glued on his dying friend – wide, teary, and desperately afraid. Izuku still twitched and struggled every now and then, but the sorrow was weighting too heavy within him for him to keep fighting.

Kacchan was dying. Kacchan was dying.

He was going to lose him forever.

The paramedic continued to perform CPR, but it didn’t seem to be working, because Aizawa offered Kaminari a dark look.

“Kaminari”, he called, and the boy’s head immediately snapped towards his teacher.

A pregnant pause. Kaminari’s eyes widened.

“Go”, Aizawa instructed firmly.

Kaminari only hesitated for a split second before he was on his feet and rushing to the paramedics.

“Stay back –“, one of them tried to warn.

“I have an electricity quirk”, Kaminari explained in a rush. “I can defibrillate him”.

The paramedics exchanged a look.

“You ever done this before, kid?”

“No, but we don’t really have time for a lesson!”, Kaminari protested, voice high pitched. Without waiting for an invitation, he kneeled down beside Kacchan, his shaking hands

hovering hesitantly above his friend's chest.

"Ok", the paramedic breathed shakily. "Does the electricity come off your hands?"

"It can", Kaminari nodded quickly.

The paramedic grabbed Kaminari's wrists with no resemblance to delicacy due to their urgency and pressed his palms above the correct spots of Kacchan's chest. His shirt had been cut open by the other two paramedics, exposing the mess of bruises that his chest had become.

"Can you control the voltage when you use your quirk?", she added.

"Yeah, yeah", Kaminari nodded emphatically.

"Then let's start with 200 volts".

"Is this a good idea?", one of the other paramedics asked – the one who was working on the transfusion.

"It's our best shot right now", the first one pointed out.

"Yeah", Kaminari nodded, even though he looked very nervous and almost green. "Just give me the cue".

"Ok", the paramedic nodded back. "Now".

Kaminari shocked Kacchan, making his still chest jolt up and fall back down. The paramedic who was in charge of stanching the bleeding held Kacchan's torso down as if to prevent the damage of the impalement to increase due to the movement.

The paramedic instructing Kaminari measured Kacchan's pulse, before offering the electric boy a nervous look.

"Again", she instructed, firm. "Make it four hundred".

Kaminari did as he was told. Kacchan's chest jolted again and his head fell to the side, limp.

More seconds passed.

"Again. Five hundred".

Kaminari failed to hold back a sob, but did as he was told.

"Come on, come on, come on, come on", he begged, watching as Kacchan's chest jolted again.

The paramedic waited.

"Again. Increase".

“Oh god”, Kaminari sobbed frantically, tears and snot running down his sweaty face as he shocked his friend. “Oh god, oh man, Bakugou, oh my god –“

“Wait!”, the paramedic exclaimed.

Everyone tensed up.

She met Kaminari’s eyes, shoulders slumping.

“I got a pulse”.

Kaminari nearly collapsed on his back from relief, a dizzy spell overcoming his stressed brain. Somewhere along the way, Kacchan’s blood, which had sprayed from the injury because of all the jolting, had found its way to Kaminari’s front.

“You saved him, kid. Thanks, but you gotta clear out of the way now”, the paramedic told Kaminari gently, but urgently. Then, she turned back to her team. “Come on, guys, we gotta move him right now”.

Kaminari stumbled out of the way with Uraraka’s help, who grabbed his shoulders and gently guided him to the side. Kaminari’s eyes were very wide and he was shaking from head to toe, almost as much as Izuku, who was still being restrained by Aizawa.

“Midoriya”, the teacher told him, strict. “We have to move with them. The whole thing is about to come down”.

Izuku felt numb, and Aizawa’s words sounded as if they were coming from underwater. His limbs were heavy and shaking, and while he was pretty sure he would faceplant on the floor as soon as he tried to get back to his feet, he knew he couldn’t stay there. Kacchan was dying. He needed – he needed to go with him. He would be able to help no one if he was buried by a building.

With Aizawa’s help, Izuku moved, at the same time Uraraka approached the team again to make the rubble impaling Kacchan float.

Then, everything happened at the same time.

Before her fingers could touch the piece of concrete, the whole structure shook and trembled, as if they were being hit by an earthquake. And, despite Izuku’s grief, sorrow, fear, and confusion, his brain was overwhelmed by a sudden clarity.

“It’s about to come down!”, one of the paramedics shouted as pebbles and dust rained down all their heads. They were about to be buried alive – and if that happened, Kacchan had no chance of surviving.

Before he thought about it, and as naturally as breathing, Izuku’s whole body was covered by green lightning. He rushed forwards, hands forming fists, but before he could get too far Aizawa held one of his arms back.

“What the hell are you thinking?!”, he shouted over the deafening noise of the building crumbling apart.

“I can do this!”, Izuku shouted back.

“Midoriya –“, he tried to scold, but another harsh trembling sent them all falling down, on their sides. Larger pieces of concrete were starting to rain down beside them, and it was only a matter of time before they were crushed to death.

Uraraka got back to her feet and was starting to jump and touch her hands to the ceiling above them, in an attempt to make the largest pieces float before they fell and crushed them. But even she had a limit, and that rubble was too heavy. She wouldn’t be able to float all the pieces long enough for them to escape, and even if she did, she would be trapped inside once they were out. No, Izuku had to do this. His quirk was back to him, he had enough muscle mass. He could do this.

They didn’t have an option.

“Don’t do this!”, Aizawa ordered him, but Izuku ignored him and rushed towards the paramedics.

“Move him closer to the opening!”, Izuku ordered, pointing at the hole in the ceiling. If they all stood beneath that, there would be smaller chances of them being crushed by the larger rubble.

“We need the girl’s quirk! This piece is too heavy, we can’t move it!”, one of the paramedics shouted, face covered by dust.

“Uraraka-san!”, Izuku shouted, calling the girl’s attention. “Leave that! Help them move Kacchan!”

Uraraka looked like she wanted to argue, but she knew there was no time. Instead of jumping at the ceiling again, she rushed towards the paramedics, following their instructions to the letter and making the piece of rubble with the metal impaling Kacchan float.

“I won’t let you kill yourself over this”, Aizawa grabbed Izuku’s arm again, a stern look on his face.

“There’s no time, sensei”, Izuku protested respectfully. “I can blow the ceiling above us to pieces small enough so they won’t crush us”.

“You haven’t used your quirk in over a year”, Aizawa tightened his grip on his arm. “There’s no guarantee your body –“

“It’s the only way”, Izuku cut him off, urgent.

“Midoriya –“

“Please, I can do this. I’m ready”, Izuku added. “I… I have to”.

Aizawa shook his head as if he didn't like it.

"Uraraka-san", Izuku yelled, eyes still locked with his teacher's, before he snapped his head to the side to look at the girl. "You need to let go".

Uraraka stared at him as if he had lost his mind.

"*What*?", she yelled back.

"Let go of the concrete on the ceiling! Leave it to me!"

"We'll be crushed!", Kaminari protested, standing protectively above Uraraka and Kacchan. They were with the paramedics directly beneath the opening.

"No, we won't!", Izuku retorted. "I've got this!"

And then he turned back to Aizawa, ignoring the floor shaking and trembling beneath them, and the sound of the building's structure coming apart.

"You too, sensei", Izuku said. "Wait with them there, it's safer. There's less rubble to crush you".

Aizawa scoffed at him, letting go of Izuku's arm.

"If you say you can do this, then *do* this, trouble kid", Aizawa snarled at him, taking a step to the side to give Izuku space to work but not giving any indication he was about to put more distance between them. "I'm staying with you, so don't fail".

Izuku stared at him, breathing heavily.

Well, now the stakes were higher. But he was glad his teacher trusted him.

He closed his eyes, and allowed One For All to run through him. Before, when he tested his theory right after Kacchan passed out, he had felt the quirk – but he had also felt resistance, as if it wasn't back to him completely. Now, the resistance was still there, but smaller and smaller.

He didn't have the time to wait, though. He needed to do this now, or they would all be crushed to death. He couldn't afford to be too careful, either – his arms were already a lost cause, but he couldn't risk using too little strength and getting everyone there killed anyway. He didn't feel stable enough to use his feet, either.

He needed to use full power, on his arm. It was the only way.

The lightning became more intense.

"Detroit…"

Then, a surge of power. It was quick, like actual lightning, pushing through him as if One For All had returned to him, completely and all at once. He readied his arm, and made a punching

movement towards the ceiling at the same time Uraraka let go of all the debris she was holding up with her quirk.

“Smash!”

He tried to remember the day All Might saved him and Kacchan from the Sludge Villain. The way he had used Detroit Smash with such force that he changed the weather. And he was able to mimic him perfectly.

The wind force was so absolutely strong that it disintegrated the ceiling above them, as well as throwing Aizawa, his friends, and everyone else back. The three paramedics had placed themselves above Kacchan to shield him, which was good, otherwise he would have been sent flying too. The after effect of the quirk lasted for a few more seconds, during which Izuku was the only person who remained standing on his feet, since he was at the epicenter of the surge of power.

Then, it was over.

Dust and tiny pebbles rained down slowly at them, like snow and hail. Even the building stabilized for a while, now that there was no longer an unstable upper floor threatening to collapse.

Silence fell upon the group. They were all looking up at the sky, baffled at how powerful Izuku’s quirk was. The ceiling was completely gone; the only evidence of it was the pebbles still falling upon them.

Then, it started to rain.

Izuku fell to his knees at the same time Aizawa got back to his feet, baffled. The boy’s right arm was a deep shade of purple, a shade Aizawa had come to know too well. The limb was clearly broken, stiff and swollen already. Izuku let it fall heavily beside his body.

“Midoriya –“, the teacher approached him, noticing that the boy was shaking and breathing heavily. Then, just as he knelt down beside the student, Izuku wrapped his good arm around his torso, which was also becoming purple.

Aizawa’s stomach dropped.

Izuku’s body went limp and he swayed on his knees, but, before he could collapse heavily to the floor, Aizawa grabbed him, picking his student into his arms in a bridal style.

“We need to move”, he rushed towards the rest of the group, carrying the trembling, half-awake Izuku. “Now. Before it starts shaking again”.

“S-Sen…sei…”, Izuku wheezed out, weak and injured.

“God damn it, Midoriya”, Aizawa scolded him, nervous. “You said you were ready”.

“S-Sorry”, Izuku choked out, eyes half-lidded. “Shouldn’ have… started with… hundred p’r cent…”

“Shut up”, Aizawa instructed nervously. “You’ll make yourself worse”.

Everything else was a flash to Izuku. The pain he was feeling, added to the remains of his concussion, was making it hard to concentrate. He saw Mount Lady’s gigantic head at one point, and assumed she was finally recovered and ready to help them again. He saw her huge hand outstretching towards them, palm up, and assumed she would move them down to safety. He allowed his eyes to slip closed for a while, before he remembered the reason why this had happened in the first place.

“Kacchan”, Izuku called, voice weak and constrained. “K-Ka… cchan…”

“Shh”, Aizawa instructed, and Izuku felt his own body move up and down painfully as his teacher jogged. “Stay quiet”.

But how could Izuku stay quiet when the person he loved the most was dying?

“K-Kacchan”, he cried, trying to look around, trying to see Kacchan. But all he could see was a blurry mess of people running, and all he could hear was an unintelligible mix of voices, saying all sorts of things he couldn’t understand.

Suddenly, the pain on his torso burned with a renewed vengeance, making him yelp and twist.

“Ruptured spleen”, an unknown voice said from above him, and only then did he realize he was no longer moving. “Definitely broken ribs. And his arm…”

“Is it bad?”, Aizawa asked from beside him, and what was he doing there? He needed… He had to make sure Kacchan would be fine.

“It’s bad, but it’s nothing we can’t handle. He’ll need surgery, but his chances are good”.

Ok, that was good and definitely a relief, but what about Kacchan?

“Kacchan”, he called again, voice weak and raspy. He tried to move, but the pain stopped him.

“We’re gonna need sedation here”, the unknown voice called loudly, and Izuku flinched. No, he couldn’t be sedated, he needed to see Kacchan!

“No one tell Bakugou about any of this”, he heard Aizawa’s voice instruct sternly.

Something cold ran up his arm and darkness enveloped him before he could call Kacchan’s name again.

And then, Izuku remembered.

“Oh my god, Kacchan! Are you ok? Kacchan, what happened to you?!”

“I just wanted to thank you. For, you know, helping me. I know you don’t want to. And… I know you don’t have to. So thanks".

“Of course I have to, you goddamn moron. What kind of hero would I be if I didn’t?”

“Guess what? I don’t fucking need you to save me, and I definitely don’t need you to go around with that smug look on your ugly face as if you’re some sort of god sent savior or some shit. So just get over yourself and deal with the fact that you’re not fucking better than me, and you never will be".

“You… really think that of me?”

“Yeah".

“And this? Can you feel this?”

“Y-Y-Yes, I can feel it! I can feel you, Kacchan!”

“I…”

“I can feel you!”

“Yeah. Yeah, I can feel you, too, Deku”.

“I gave my life for yours. Do you really think I did that because I was pretending to care? Or because I wanted recognition? Or because of any of the other reasons you came up with?”

“Shut up!”

“It was because I care about you, and I didn’t want you to die! Is that really so hard to believe?”

“Yes! Yes, it fucking is hard to believe!”

“Why? I don’t understand, Kacchan. I respect you and admire you. I – I understand if you don’t respect me or admire me. I never asked you to. I – I haven’t earned it yet, not really. But that is still a long way away from thinking – from thinking those things you think of me. I don’t understand why you think I would be – using you or – or this other stuff you say sometimes. I don’t understand why you close yourself off from your friends”.

“He was being nice to you. It wouldn’t hurt to be nice back”.

“Yes, it would”.

“No, Kacchan, it wouldn’t! Why don’t you just try it?”

“Why the fuck didn’t you tell me you were in fucking pain?! I’ve been dealing with your shitty backache the entire goddamn time because you just couldn’t put some use into your trap for fucking once!”

“W-What? What are you talking about?!”

“If you feel the pain I feel, then I feel the pain you feel, too!”

“Since the old woman said you need to sleep on an actual bed so that none of us gets fucking backpains like a pair of old-ass losers, I am mercifully allowing you to sleep on my bed, since I know it’s fucking amazing”.

“Wow”, Izuku said in a deadpan, unimpressed. “Thanks, Kacchan”.

“You keep that fucking attitude up and I’ll shove your bony ass back into that floor, no matter how bad it hurts my back”.

“Fine, fine, go on. What’s the rule?”

“The rule is that you don’t fucking cross the pillow fort”.

“You’re wearing glasses”.

“I’m glad to know your brain still works, even if it seems to be as fucking dull as ever”.

“I – I like katsudon. “Can you make that?”

“I’ll see what I can do”.

“How am I supposed to get my shit together when you’re the one who’s fucking *teasing my friends and making stuff up instead of being useful?!”*

“Did you just – did you just curse at me?”

“You think they’ll think less of you if you help me. You think they’ll see it as a weakness if you help the one person who has been nothing but your rival so far. But that’s not true. They’ll see it as kindness”.

“That’s worse”.

“What? Why?”

“If there’s one thing I’m not is kind, shitty Deku. You, of all people, should know that”.

“Ok, you do have a point. But people can change. I’ve changed”.

“Oh, yeah? Well, I don’t want to change”.

“We aren’t friends, Deku. We’ll never be. We’re nothing but rivals who happened to get stuck together and now are surviving together. Once you get back to your body, everything will go back to the way it used to be. I won’t cook for you anymore. I won’t share a bed with you anymore. Hell, I probably won’t even talk to you anymore. I’m only doing those things because I have to – because I’m meant to, not because I want to. Because I’ll get a fucking headache and feel like shit if I don’t. Is that what you wanted to hear? Is that what you wanted to know?”

“We used to be”.

“What?”

“We used to be. Friends, I mean. To this day, I never really figured out why we ever stopped”.

“Well, rack your fucking brains”.

“Yeah, I supposed you’re right. We stopped being friends because you had a quirk, and I didn’t”.

“Yeah”.

“And you thought you were better than me. That I wasn’t worthy of your friendship”.

“Fucking right”.

“And you didn’t want anyone to know you used to be best friends with a quirkless loser”.

“But guess what, Kacchan? I have a quirk now. And I’m making it my own. And, one day, the quirkless loser who you were ashamed of and who you abandoned will be better than you. And I’ll never, ever shove it in your face, because I don’t want to be a hero in order to surpass you or to be better. I want to be a hero to save people. Can you say the same?”

“Listen, Deku – what I’m trying to say is: I didn’t know how much I hurt you until I felt it firsthand. I don’t know what I was trying to do, but I didn’t mean for you to be in so much pain. So my bad, I guess”.

“Really? ‘My bad’?”

“I don’t know what you want me to say”.

“I don’t know. A proper apology would be nice”.

“I told you I don’t fucking do apologies”.

“Then you’re going to have to do better than ‘my bad’”.

“Tch. You think way too much of yourself”.

“You told me to kill myself”.

Silence.

“Do you remember that?”

“Yeah”.

“Yeah”.

“I didn’t mean it”.

“I don’t think it really matters what you meant, Kacchan”.

“You know, you seem really eager to be friends with the guy you keep insisting hurts you so much. If I was that much of an asshole, if I hurt you so bad, then just leave me alone and stop insisting on this friendship bullshit”.

“Fine”.

“Listen, shitty Deku. I don’t want you to die. I never did. I was just more of an asshole than I am now. I said shit without thinking first. I still do, sometimes, but – I’m not like that anymore. Or at least I’m trying not to be”.

“Yeah, I know that”.

“Then just let it go, ok?”

“You’d like that, wouldn’t you?”

“What the fuck is that supposed to mean, you sassy son of a bitch?”

“It’s easier if I just forgive you without you actually having to apologize. But even if I do that, the pain won’t just go away”.

“Of course. Because it can’t be that fucking easy with you, can it?”

“Yeah”.

“How long have you been feeling it?”

“Hm?”

“This pain”.

“I don’t know. It gets better, sometimes”.

“When does it get worse?”

“When you’re mean to me for no reason”.

“So all the time, then”.

“Not always. Sometimes, when you’re not really thinking about it, you can be nice”.

“Not to you, though”.

“No. Not to me”.

“I’ll find a way to make it up to you, then”.

“Why?”

“I don’t know. Because I feel like it. Don’t fucking question me”.

“You could just apologize. It’s simple like that”.

“I’ll apologize when I’m dead”.

“Or when I am”.

“Either way, it doesn’t really matter if you’re draining my energy”.

“It… doesn’t?”

“No, it doesn’t, stupid Deku. Because – and I can’t fucking believe I’m about to say this shit to you –, until we find a way to put you back where you belong, you ain’t going anywhere. You hear me?”

“Why would you put your life on the line like that for me?”

“I could ask you the same fucking question”.

“How’s the pain?”

“It’s – It’s n-not that b-bad, now. I’ve been through worse”.

“Yeah, of course you fucking have. You break your bones every other damn day”.

“Kacchan”.

“Hm”.

“Thanks for pulling me back”.

“You think I’d just let you be dragged by the fucking train until we arrived?”

“I – I’m sorry. Of course I didn’t think that. But still – thank you”.

“Whatever, shitty Deku”.

“He was such a cheerful kid… He used to love playing heroes and making up hero names for himself. After he got diagnosed… There wasn’t anything he could have done other than reach out for the closest thing he had to a hero. I think he wanted you to be the hero he thought he would never get to be, you know?”

“Whatever. Just thank her for the katsudon. It was so good!”

“Was it better than mine?”

“What?”

“Her katsudon. Is it better than mine?”

Hesitation.

“You fucker. I’ll never cook for you again”.

“But I didn’t even say anything!”

“Your silence said enough”.

“That’s overdramatic, Kacchan”.

“Shut the fuck up. You’ll never taste my katsudon again”.

“But it’s my mom’s cooking! You can’t compete with that!”

“Of course I fucking can. I’m the best of the best”.

“Deku. Deku, holy fuck, wake up…”

“Deku. Don’t you fucking dare, just wake the hell up, you fucker –“

“Deku!”

“You goddamn son of a bitch! Don’t fucking do that again, what the fuck were you thinking? You piece of fucking shit!”

“Wha’…? Wha’ happ’nd?”

“You fucking passed out!”

“Kacchan. Are you ok? Are you feeling better?”

“Your mom was right about you. You really are a fucking loser”.

“Uh, my mom never said that”.

“Yeah, but she asked me to take care of you because you have no self-preservation skills whatso fucking ever, and she was right about that. Hence, you’re a loser”.

“Kacchan –“

“I fucking punched you, Deku. And don’t tell me it doesn’t fucking hurt or whatever bullshit you’re about to shove at me to make me feel better, because my nose is throbbing and stinging as fuck”.

“Yes. But I know you didn’t mean it. I can feel your guilt it, too”.

“While you were busy being a pathetic wimp I was working hard to get where I wanted”.

“I worked hard, too, you know. You know Dagobah?”

“The beach park?”

“Yes. It was filled with trash that came from the sea and that people threw there once it became too polluted”.

“Yeah. The place became shit in just a few years”.

“I cleaned it up”.

“What?”

“I cleaned it up. It was part of All Might’s training to pass One For All to me”.

“You cleaned up that entire beach?”

“Yes. I spent the entire time before the UA entrance exam doing that. And training. Every day. Every free time I had, I – I trained. Night and day. So that I could be worthy of inheriting All Might’s power. So that I could be worthy of getting where I am. So that I could be worthy of being at the same place as you”.

Kacchan continued to stare at him.

“I – I may not have trained for as long as you did. Or as hard as you did. And – I may have been born quirkless. But I didn’t get where I am without effort. A – A lot of people helped me, that’s true, and without them… I wouldn’t be where I am. But I worked hard. And I tried hard. Maybe not as hard as you did, but – but I still tried my best. I felt like you should know that”.

“I just mean I’ve never seen you cut anyone’s hair! How do I know you won’t mess mine up?”

“There’s no way it’ll be more messed up than it already is, loser; you can barely see with those bangs in your eyes”.

“Just ask someone else to do it, then!”

“Like hell I will. I can do it myself”.

“But I don’t want you to!”

“Do I look like I give a shit?”

“I do! It’s my hair!”

“Well, too bad for you”.

“Look, it’s not my fault I thought that, ok?! You’re the one who’s never lost an opportunity to make me feel bad about myself!”

“Ok. So, I’ve been in a coma for a while now”.

“Yeah”.

“And that means I was supposed to look… bad, right?”

“Yeah”.

“But – I didn’t – I didn’t look bad. I looked worse than bad”.

“I don’t know what the fuck that’s supposed to mean”.

“I looked dead, Kacchan”.

“That’s also fucking expectable”.

“You don’t understand. If – if anything goes wrong – if the power goes off for some reason, if someone as much as – as – pokes my body – I’m – I’m pretty sure –“

“Tell me how bad we’re talking”.

“Really bad. I mean, really, really bad”.

“You’re right”.

“I… am?”

“Yeah. Icy Hot’s plan is too risky. I’m not doing it”.

“Oh. Oh, okay”.

“What? You really think I’m gonna risk my fucking license for your nerdy ass? C’mon, Deku”.

“No, I mean – you – you’re right. It’s too risky. You shouldn’t do it”.

“I know. Now can you let me finish my fucking shower in peace or do you plan or staying in the damn bathroom to watch?”

“Hm. Is it because I tried to attack Icy Hot?”

“No”.

“But it has to do with Icy Hot, right? Your face is all red and shit”.

“No, it’s not!”

“Yes, it is. Do you have the hots for him or some shit? Is that it?”

“W-W-What?!”

“Oh, come on. He was the one who visited you the most before the old lady locked him out. He’s willing to risk his damn chance at becoming a hero just because of your stupid ass. And you get all stuttery and flushy like some sort of fairy tale princess whenever he’s around or someone mentions him. I’m not stupid”.

“I – I don’t have – I don’t – I mean – T-Todoroki-kun is – he’s – I –“

“Deep breaths, Deku. If you faint because of Icy Hot, I’m not dragging your ass along”.

“It’s not him! It's not. Him, I mean. I – we – we don’t have anything. I d-don’t – I don’t have t-the hots for him, or whatever it is you’re thinking!”

“I don’t give a shit who you have the hots for, nerd. I just want to know why you’re so upset. Is it because I tried to attack him or not?”

“No”.

“But does it have to do with him?”

“No. I mean, yes. I don’t know”.

(I, for one, know Midoriya’s life is worth the risk.)

“Pff. Whatever. If you want to get into his pants or some crap like that, wait until you’re back in your body. This is the kind of shit that I’m not doing for you, even if you paid me actual

money. Though I'm sure you won't be able to handle it on your own".

"Kacchan. I don't like Todoroki-kun like that".

"I don't give a shit who you like".

"Ah, fuck. Kirishima's handwriting sucks. Move aside, nerd; let met me grab my reading glasses".

And he put on his reading glasses.

Yeah. Izuku had it bad.

He had it so bad.

"What if I don't want to tell you?"

"Ah, there you fucking go again. Seriously, Deku?"

"I mean it. I don't have any obligation to tell you. You never tell me why you're angry; why should I tell you why I'm sad?"

"What the fuck do you mean?"

"It's true! Why don't you tell me why you're so angry, huh?"

"I'm angry 'cause you're being a piece of fucking shit who's making me exhausted with all your feelings and you refuse to tell me why!"

"Fine! Then why were you angry yesterday? And the day before that? And every single day before that? Why are you always so angry, Kacchan?"

"I don't know! I don't fucking know! What does this have to do with any fucking thing?!"

"You're really amazing, because you're terrific at looking past your anger when you're in battle, and when you're thinking strategically, and when you're acting as a hero. But the moment it is important – the moment you need to set your anger aside and just open your eyes, you don't do it! No matter how close the truth is to your face!"

“I have no fucking idea what you’re talking about”.

“I’m talking about me! I’m talking about all those times I trailed after you, and praised you, and admired you, and you spent all these years, you spent all these years thinking I was looking down on you! Because of your stupid, blinding anger!”

“So this shit is still about that? About the way I treated you as a kid?”

“This shit is about you, Kacchan. Why can’t you just see?”

“See what? What, Deku? What the fuck is it that you see and I don’t? Why the fuck do you get so upset every other day about the same damn reason? You want to talk about it? Again? Is that all you ever want to fucking talk about? Fine. I was an asshole. I fucking know that, you fucking know that. The whole damn world fucking knows that. What else do you want me to tell you?”

“Nothing I say can take back what I did. Nothing I do can erase what I’ve done. I’m trying to be fucking better, because that’s the only thing I can do, but you’re not making it fucking easy on me because whenever the fuck I try to be more reasonable and talk to you like you so wanted me to, you give me the cold shoulder and the silent treatment as if I fucking owe you something. And I don’t”.

Silence.

“Just because I was an asshole, doesn’t mean I’m indebted for life with you. I’m fucking trying, ok? I’m trying, and you’re not helping, and it’s pissing the fuck out of me, so just get your shit together and figure out what the fuck it is you want me to do, because honestly, I’m getting fed up with this. I told you to tell me when I was being an asshole to you. So if whatever got you so sad has to do with me, just tell me”.

Silence.

“I’m not fucking good at this, Deku. I’m good at everything else, but not at this feelings shit. So just tell me what the fuck is going on, because I’m tired, and I need a nap, and I’m so done with this empathic link bullshit”.

“Y-You’re – You’re right, Kacchan. I shouldn’t have given you the silent treatment. And – I shouldn’t have yelled. I’m sorry”.

“Never mind the fucking yelling, just tell me how to make you happy”.

“Why the fuck do you want to be my friend so badly?”

“B-Because – Because I – I –“

“Quit the fucking stuttering, you know I hate this crap”.

“Because, despite everything, I still think you’re amazing. I always have. And I care about you. Is it too much to wish you would care about me back?”

“You… can’t force yourself to be happy”.

“Yeah”.

I can’t force myself to care about you, either.

The words were left unsaid. Kacchan didn’t have to say them. Izuku was smart enough to understand that the silence that lingered in the air were enough of an answer.

“I’m – I’m sorry. I didn’t mean to – I didn’t – It’s just – You looked like you could use a hug. I’m sorry if I made you uncomfortable –“

“Deku could feel it”.

“… W-What?”

“He could feel your hug”.

“Kacchan…”

“He… could? Can I… Can I hug you again? Properly, this time?”

“Can we please talk about this? Please?”

“You wanna talk about it?”

“Yes, Kacchan”.

“Fine. Call me by my first name, then”.

“Seriously?”

“Yeah. I’m serious as hell”.

“I want to talk about the hug –“

“And I want to talk about me”.

“As usual”.

“Shut the fuck up and go ahead. Say it”.

“No”.

“It’s simple, Deku. Just say it. Katsuki”.

“No!”

“You can’t, can you?”

“Stop it”.

“No”.

“You’re being childish”.

“So are you, since you can’t say something as simple as Katsuki”.

“Don’t mock me about it!”

“Why not? It’s funny as fuck”.

“Stop it! It’s not!”

“Is that why you still call me Kacchan?”

Silence.

“Oh my fucking god. It is. And here I thought for all those years that you were patronizing me. Turns out you’re just dumb”.

“I'm not dumb!”

"Yeah, sure, Deku".

"S-Sorry… It's just --"

"It's just what? You think you know any fucking thing about me just because you can feel what I feel? Just because we have a shitty empathic bond that drains us the fuck out more often than it's fucking tolerable? You think you know any fucking thing about me just because you decided to trail after me when you were a brat and you haven't stopped ever since? Is that what you think?"

Izuku threw himself off the bed and onto Kacchan, enveloping him in a tight hug.

"I'm sorry. I should have realized it sooner".

Izuku tilted his head so that he could look at him, his arms still enveloping Kacchan.

"Is this ok?"

Kacchan wriggled himself away from Izuku's arms and Izuku let him go as soon as he sensed resistance coming from Kacchan.

"I'm sorry if I made you uncomfortable. It's just – I thought you needed a hug".

Kacchan didn't say anything.

"You – The way you reacted when my mom hugged you, it made me realize. I don't think I remember seeing you hug someone, really hug someone, in all those years we've known each other. And – And I told you before. About the affection thing. You – You don't know how to show it. Don't you… Long for it? Because… I mean, one of the things I miss the most about being in my body is… Is being able to touch people a-and… I know this may sound w-w-weird and s-stupid, b-but… It's n-n-nice. B-Being able to touch you. Even if… we don't really t-touch much. And I t-think… It might be good for us. Emotionally, I-I m-mean. I n-never got to know your m-mom much, but… She didn't hug you much, did she?"

"I know it upsets you when I'm sad. And I'm trying to control it better, like y-you're controlling your anger better. And I'm really glad and thankful that you keep trying to make me happy and that you took m-me to see my mom".

Another pause.

"So can you please… Can you let me try to m-make you happy, too? I don't know how to do it and I'm sorry. But – I want t-to try. I want to help you, Kacchan".

Kacchan yanked his wrist away from Izuku's hold at the words.

"I k-know you don't need my help. But I'd want to give it t-to you anyway. N-Not because I think you're a charity case, but… It's…"

For the first time ever, Izuku gave up. This was too much for him, too.

"I'll… I'll be here for you if you need me, ok? Sorry if – if I made you uncomfortable. I didn't mean to".

"Do it again".

"W-What?"

“You fucking heard me, you asshole. I’m not saying it again”.

Izuku crossed the distance between them and looked deep into Kacchan’s eyes, as if asking for permission.

“Are you sure?”

“If you hesitate one fucking second longer I’m not letting you put your hands on me ever fucking again”.

Izuku sighed and enveloped Kacchan with his arms once more before he could change his mind, this time much gentler than before. He buried his face in Kacchan’s chest.

“Fuck, I can’t believe the reason you’ve been calling me Kacchan all those years was because you didn’t know how to actually pronounce my name”.

“That wasn’t the only reason!”

“Sure wasn’t”.

“It was not!”

“Yeah, right”.

“What, are you saying you’d rather have me calling you Bakugou?”

Katsuki tensed up, his stomach twisting. He could feel Izuku tense up as well.

A pregnant, awkward pause.

“That was so weird”.

“Tell me the fuck about it”.

“Let’s agree to never do it again?”

“Whatever”.

“Kacchan”.

“Hmm”.

“Psst. Kacchan. Are you awake?”

“Hmpf”.

“Hey. I can’t tell if you’re awake or not just by grunting. You’re always grunting”.

Katsuki shifted, covering his face with a pillow.

“Really?”

“Shuddup”, he groaned, voice sleepy and hoarse.

A sigh.

“Fine. I’ll wait until you’re awake”.

“Hmm”.

“Why don’t you ever listen, huh?”

“Everything’s as clear as day, but you still don’t see it”.

“I don’t know what I have to do for you to see”.

“…Whatcha doing?”

“What the fuck does it look like I’m doing?”

“I’m – I don’t…?“

“Stop making such a fuss about this. I don’t wanna feel cold, you don’t wanna feel cold, so that’s all there is to this”.

“You’re feelin’ cold?”

“The fuck do you think, asshole? I can feel what you feel, so take a guess”.

“Kacchan, you don’ have–“

“Just shut up and stop making this weird”.

Throwing the last pillow down on the floor, Kacchan dragged himself to the center of the bed, now that he had dismantled the pillow fort. Izuku continued to stare at him, trying to figure out whether he was still asleep and this was a dream, or if he was awake and this was actually happening. He only moved when Kacchan outstretched an arm to the side and gave him an impatient eyebrow raise.

Izuku swallowed dry and dragged himself closer to Kacchan on the bed. He was hesitant, but also too sleepy to put much thought into his actions. Kacchan didn't move – he simply lied still, one of his arms outstretched in order to support Izuku, waiting for the boy to nestle against him and use him as a human furnace.

Izuku was very silent as he rested his head on the spot between Kacchan's shoulder and his chest, face purposefully blank and eyes blinking stupidly. Kacchan could feel just how tense he was as he closed his arm around Izuku's torso, holding him in place. He, himself, was also tense.

Neither of them spoke. All they could hear was each other's breathing in the otherwise silent room.

"Can you tell Kirishima-kun I wished him a happy birthday?"

"Fine".

"And that I'll get him a birthday present as soon as I'm back in my body?"

"He doesn't really care about that, to be real".

"And that I'm sorry I can't give him an actual hug right now –"

"Why don't you just fucking write him a letter already?"

Izuku sighed, lowering his head in silence.

Kacchan sighed as well.

"Fine, shitty Deku. I'll tell him all that crap".

"Ok".

"No 'thank you, Kacchan'?"

"If you don't have to say 'sorry', then I don't have to say 'thank you'".

"That's rude as fuck".

"Oh, and you're not, Kacchan?"

"I'm allowed to be rude".

"What does that even mean?"

"It means I'm fucking allowed to be rude. It's just my personality".

“Uh, that’s not how it works, actually. And that’s a terrible excuse”.

“Shut up. I get to be rude. You don’t get to be impolite”.

“I don’t think so”.

“I’ll kick your ghost ass”.

“I’ll say ‘thank you’ if you say ‘sorry’”.

“I’ll say ‘sorry’ if you say my name”.

“Kacchan”.

“That’s not my name”.

“Stop mocking me”.

“Never”.

“You’re mean”.

“That’s my charm”.

“What’s your deal with her, anyway?”

“W-What? W-What do you mean?!”

“Your deal with Round Face. She clearly has the hots for you”.

“Kacchan! Don’t say things like that!”

“Oh, come on. Everyone can fucking see it. Look at her reaction just because of Dunce Face’s teasing”.

“S-She’s… She’s my friend. Only that”.

“If you say so”.

“Wait, I have an idea! You could – You could darg – uh, drag, drag me around!”

“And what the fuck is that gonna prove?”

“Oh, no, wait, I mean, I can drag you around! Sorry, I confused us. It’s confusing. I can drag you around!”

“Like hell I’m letting that happen”, Kacchan scoffed, but, completely ignoring him, Izuku released himself from his grasp and stumbled forwards before regaining his footing. Then, before Kacchan could react, he threw himself onto him again. “Oi. Oi. The fuck are you doing, asshole?”, Kacchan asked, annoyed, pushing Izuku slightly back.

“I’m gonna hold you up!”, Izuku exclaimed, grabbing Kacchan all over as if he wasn’t sure how he should hold him in order to lift him up.

“Deku. Get the fuck off me”, Kacchan warned through gritted teeth, but Izuku didn’t pay him any mind. Everyone was staring.

“You were trying to interact with me to prove I’m here, bu’ I think it’s easier if I interact with you”, Izuku explained drunkenly. He crouched over and attempted to pick Kacchan up bridal style, but before he could, Kacchan shoved him away.

“Stop this shit right now! There’s no way in hell I’m letting you pick me up!”

“Come on, Kacchan! Pretty pretty pretty pretty pleeeease”, Izuku moaned, losing balance and leaning heavily on Kacchan’s front again. He giggled.

“Deku, if you don’t get a grip of your fucking self I’m gonna knock you the fuck out”, Kacchan threatened. “It’s easier to drag your ass around than to deal with you like this. I should have fucking figured out you’re the annoying-drunk type”.

“I’m no’ annoying. I’m super cool”, Izuku giggled, burying his face on Kacchan’s chest. “And you’re the one who go’ me drunkey”.

“Yeah, because I didn’t think your assholery would be increased by a tenfold. And you’re not fucking cool”.

“All Might thinks I’m cool”.

“What does All Might even know?”

“Uhhh…? Everything, Kacchan? Kacchan. Kacchan. Kacchakacchakaccha. I really love your name”.

“Truth or dare, Bakubro?”, Mina asked, sounding way more excited than she should be. Immediately knowing she was up to something, Katsuki knew he would end up getting wrecked if he chose truth.

“Dare”, he said triumphantly, challenge evident in his eyes.

“I dare you to give Kiri a peck on the cheek!”

“What?!”

“Ooooh!”

“Mina, you’re asking for it, aren’t you!”

“Rest in peace, Mina-chan”.

“That’s not allowed, is it?”

“Like fucking hell I will!”, Katsuki grunted out.

“It’s a dare, Bakugou! You can’t turn out from a dare!”, Mina pointed out. “Consider it a birthday gift!”

“I already got him a birthday gift!”, Katsuki growled. Izuku was very quiet beside him.

“Which he hasn’t opened yet!”, Sero pointed out.

“That’s hardly my fucking business, is it?”

“Bakugou, it’s ok, man”, Kirishima chuckled, raising his hands in a calming gesture and looking like he was trying to promote peace among the group. “You don’t have to do it, it’s fine”.

“You don’t have to do it”, Mina shrugged dismissively. “But if you don’t, you’re a chicken”.

“Do you have a deathwish?!”, Sero exclaimed, giving Mina a horrified look.

“Bakubro could never hurt me!”, Mina blew Bakugou a kiss.

“Try your luck, Raccoon Eyes”, Katsuki growled animalistically.

“Mina can choose some other dare!”, Kirishima tried to offer.

“Oh, Mina can choose a lot of other dares”, Mina smirked evilly. Kirishima eyed her with a pleading look, aware that Katsuki wasn’t in a mood to be played with. “If he didn’t want to be challenged, he should have picked truth instead”, she added, unrelenting. “Now, he either does my dare or he’s a”, she mimicked a chicken using her arms. “Coward!”

“Oh, I’ll fucking show you who the fucking coward is”, Katsuki snarled, surging forwards but being held back by Kirishima’s hand on his chest.

“It’s just a peck on the cheek! It’s no biggie!”, Mina provided.

“Mina, stop teasing him”, Kirishima pleaded, still holding Katsuki back.

“Never! Bakugou is the coolest to tease!”, she chuckled, and only then Katsuki noticed she was a bit intoxicated as well. That explained why she seemed to have lost her fucking sense of

self-preservation.

"You suck at dares, Raccoon Eyes", Katsuki growled, slowly nudging Deku away so that he could turn to Kirishima, who was sitting right beside him and still holding a hand to his chest. "You'd better hope not to catch me on a next round, because I'll fuck you up no matter what you choose".

"Bakugou, really, you don't have to –", Kirishima tried to say as Katsuki approached him, but was interrupted by the boy dropping a quick, barely feelable kiss on his cheek. He blushed, and Katsuki simply sat back down as if that had been no big deal. Most of the members of the circle failed to see the peck, since it had been so quick, but Mina, who had been watching closely and with sharp attention, widened her eyes in surprise and shock.

"Oh my god, he actually did it!", she exclaimed.

"I told you I ain't no fucking coward, you dumbass!", Katsuki shouted.

"That was the manliest kiss… Anyone has ever given me…", Kirishima said in a heartfelt way.

"Ah, shut the fuck up", Katsuki rolled his eyes.

Instead of leaning his head on his shoulder again, like he had been doing before Katsuki moved, Izuku decided to stay sitting upright. Katsuki spared him a single questioning look, but when the boy didn't meet his eyes, a blank expression on his face, he decided to ignore him. Deku was probably just feeling the effect of the alcohol or some shit like that.

"Would it help if I tried to say your first name? I think I'll probably regret this because you'll definitely mock me forever, but you're being weirdly silent and you're not calling me annoying, so I'm getting really worried right now, Katchuki –"

"You're dying".

An awkward pause.

"Uh… W-What?"

"You're dying".

Another pause.

"Yeah… I – I know that".

"No, you fucking don't".

Silence.

“You don’t know shit, shitty Deku. You got fucking wasted last night”.

Izuku blushed slightly.

“Y-Yeah… That, I remember”.

“I asked Earphone Girl to help me eavesdrop on All Might”.

A pregnant pause.

“You… what?”

“He received a phone call when we were listening. He said some shit about a capture today, at Hosu. He also said some shit about the quirk that hit you having a countdown, and that you’re going to die in five days unless they capture the villain”.

Izuku stared at him in silence.

Kacchan stared back. He looked nothing but angry, now, but at least that wasn’t so unsettling. His rage was almost comforting, at this point.

The silence stretched.

“I figured you should know”.

“So you’re not gonna cry your fucking eyes out or some shit like that?”

“No, because I’m not going to die”.

“Yeah”.

“I mean it”.

“I know. You’re not”.

Izuku went silent, frankly a bit surprised by the lack of resistance or teasing from the boy. He stared at Kacchan through the mirror with a quizzical look on his face. Kacchan stared back.

“What? You think I’m gonna just fucking sit here and watch your shitty soul fall apart or something? Or worse – do you think I’ll risk getting stuck with your shitty ghost presence for the rest of my life?”

“What? What do you mean?”

“I mean I’m taking some fucking action, like the damn pros should have done a long fucking time ago”.

“Kacchan”, he said, a serious warning in his tone. “You’re not saying –“

“I’m saying what I’m fucking saying”.

“And what, exactly, is that?”, Izuku insisted, worried. “What do you mean you’re taking action? What do you plan to do?”

“The fuck do you think it is?”

“I don’t know”, Izuku said seriously, not breaking eye contact. “And I don’t think I’ll like the answer”.

“I just don’t get it, Kacchan. One day, you hate me. The other day, we’re stuck together, and we seem to be building something, something better than we had before, and then you have these moments where it feels like you’ve gone all the way back to hating me again. Then one day we’re hugging, and on the next you can barely stand to look at me”.

Kacchan continued to stare at him, his anger increasing.

“I just don’t know what you want from me. I don’t know what you’re thinking. I don’t know what you want me to do”.

“I want you to shut the fuck up and not second guess me”.

Izuku stared at him for a few silent moments before shaking his head. His eyes were finally getting moist, now.

“No”, he protested, firm, even though his voice was starting to give off that ugly wobble that he hated so much. “I won’t let you do this”

“You can do us all a favor and shove that self-sacrificial bullshit you love to pull so much right back up your petulant fucking ass”.

Izuku snorted, indignant.

“Oh, I’m petulant?”

“Yes, you fucking are”.

“You’re the one who thinks it’s such a great idea to follow the pro heroes on the manhunt of a guy who could have very well gotten you killed! How am I the petulant one?”

“You risked your fucking license coming after me, didn’t you?”

Izuku stared up at him, silent. Kacchan scoffed.

"There. You got your payback, now".

"I don't want any payback, Kacchan", Izuku shook his head. "I didn't do it for a reward".

"I don't care what you did it for".

"He could have killed you last time".

"I wouldn't have gotten fucking killed".

"No, because I got in the way! And I can't do it again this time!"

"I don't fucking need you to save me, you piece of shit".

"And you don't need to risk your hero career over me, either!"

"What the fuck is it with you; do you actually want to fucking die?", he pushed Izuku away. "Do you want me to let these bastards get you killed? Because trust me, shitty Deku, you're really fucking close to convincing me I should just let you drop dead".

"Well, that would be easier to understand than this!"

Kacchan halted.

Izuku stared at him, panting. He stared back.

"You really wanna know why the fuck I wanna go after the pros and make sure they get to save your stupid ass? "Because I don't give a shit if you have a death wish or an attention kink – I ain't gonna be dragged down with you because of it".

Izuku blinked at him, a flash of hurt confusion coursing through his eyes. Kacchan breathed out.

"W-What?", Izuku asked, nervous.

"I don't wanna risk having my soul dragged along with yours if you die".

"What are you thinking about?"

"Huh?"

“You’ve been staring at the fucking window for thirty minutes. Even if there was a fucking All Might parade out there you wouldn’t stare for so long”.

“I don’t know. I’m just thinking”.

“Which is a fucking surprise to us all, but you still haven’t said what about”.

Izuku sighed.

“About life. About… everything”.

Kacchan stared at him.

“The day is really nice today”.

“Really?”

“I like it when it’s like this”.

“Like what?”

“It’s sunny, but not too hot. The breeze is cold, and there are clouds in the sky… Everything is calm and silent. All you can hear is the sound of the leaves when the wind hits them”.

“Yeah, I could fucking use some calm and silence”.

A small chuckle.

“I agree”.

A pause.

“The fuck is that supposed to mean?”

“Everything’s been messy for you ever since the villain attacked us”.

“Tch. Tell me the fuck about it”.

“I supposed… You’d be happy to have some peace”.

Kacchan stared at him for long moments. His gaze was scorching.

Izuku went back to staring out the window.

“The fuck is wrong with you?”

Izuku looked at him again, the hint of a confused frown between his eyes.

“Huh…?”

“I asked what the fuck is wrong with you. Did your fucking mom drop you on your head as a baby or some shit?”

Izuku downright frowned at him.

“I… I don’t understand, Kacchan”.

“You think I’m about to drag my ass over to Hosu in the middle of the damn night just because I want some fucking peace and quiet? You think that’s what I’ll get once you’re gone?”

Izuku stared at him in silence.

“Yeah, because I’m such a fucking monster that of fucking course I’ll feel happiness if you die as a result of taking a fucking blow in my place. So tell me, did your mom drop you as a baby? Or were you born fucked up in the head? Because those are the only two explanations I have for you to look up to me like you insist you do, despite all the fucked-up shit I did to you”.

“I’ve already told you several fucking times over that I was an asshole to you, that I know I was a fucking asshole. And guess what? I’m still an asshole, but I’m not as bad as I was before. And I find it pretty fucking offensive that I’m going through all this trouble to save you shitty life, and you still think that I’ll be fucking happy to see you gone. I don’t give a shit if you have a death wish or a god-complex. You want to die a fucking martyr? Good for you. But I won’t let you fucking use me as your damn scapegoat. I didn’t fucking ask you to be my human fucking shield, and I won’t let you die because of it. I’m gonna go after the pros, I’m gonna kick the villain’s ass, and I’m gonna shove your shitty soul back into your body. If you’ve got a problem with that, keep it to your fucking self”.

Izuku was still staring at him, looking at a loss for words.

“I’m going to save your dumb ass, whether you fucking want it or not. And that’s the sort of fucking hero you should fucking admire”.

“I never admired you because you were cruel”.

A pause.

“I mean… You were cruel. You were really cruel. But that was never the reason why I looked up to you. I did it because… Well”.

Another pause.

"You're amazing, Kacchan. I know I say it a lot, and I know you know it. But for a person like me to admire a person like you, it takes… something. You had to be really incredible for me to be able to look past all the stuff you did. So yes, you beat me, and you called me names, and you put me down… You… Y-You did things that I… That I still have trouble forgetting about. Some of the stuff you said to me, they… It left a mark. I can't overlook that. But I – I'm not a masochist. It all hurt. But it is like you said… There's no use dwelling in the past".

Hesitation.

"I already forgave you for all that. I… I need you to know that I did. And I admired you because of your skill. You have an amazing quirk, a powerful quirk. You had everything I wished for, but I never envied you for it… Because I – I knew t-that if anyone deserved to be grand, it was you. The way you mastered your quirk at such a young age, t-the way you trained hard and earned your place at UA… The – The way you always excelled at everything you did. The way you always worked hard to be the best, and the way you knew you earned your place… Those were the reasons why I admired you".

Kacchan kept his eyes buried on the crook of his arm.

"I admired you because you never gave up. You always worked hard. You always did your best. In my eyes, you are the very definition of what Plus Ultra means. B-But what I admired the most was t-that… It didn't matter how hard things were. You never, ever gave up. You never give up, Kacchan. Whenever there is a wall in front of you, you laugh".

Silence.

"You are my image of victory. That's why I know I won't die. And despite everything you did to me… I still love you, Kacchan. I always have".

Kacchan stared at him.

"And I trust you. I know that we are going to find a way out of this".

"You're my image of a hero. Not because of your flaws, but despite them".

"All I'm saying is that… Well. I hope we don't go back to…", he trailed off.

"To what?"

"You know. What we had before".

"So fucking nothing?"

“What we had was worse than nothing. It was…”

A pause.

“It wasn’t nice. I mean, it was slowly getting better, but it wasn’t… nice. And what we have now, well…”, Izuku shrugged. “I like it better”.

Silence.

“I know you like it better, too. Even if you don’t admit it”.

“You don’t know shit about me”.

Izuku smiled.

“Actually, I think I’m finally starting to get you”.

“I’m sorry”.

Kacchan sighed.

“What for?”

“I don’t want you to get expelled”.

“I don’t fucking want that either”.

“But if you do this –“

Kacchan stopped on his tracks.

“Then I’ll be no fucking hero. It would be better to just hang the coat and chase another fucking career”.

Izuku stared at him.

“A hero is more than a fucking quirk, Deku”.

Izuku’s eyes widened slightly.

“What is the use of having these”, he raised his hands up, “if I cower beneath a bunch of D-listers? If I go back to my fucking room and let these assholes infiltrate UA just because of a fucking license?”

Izuku’s eyes were filled with emotion and determination.

“I took my fucking time, but I finally learned it”, Kacchan said before he turned on his heels and walked away.

“Kacchan!”

“Deku”, he grunted, voice barely above a whisper, stumbling his way towards the boy. He couldn’t stand up, but that didn’t mean he had to stand still.

“Bakugou, wait!”

“What are you doing?!”

“Deku”, he managed to put more energy into his voice.

“Bakugou, where are you going?”

“What’s going on?!”

“He’s resistant, this one, isn’t he?”, the man scorned past chapped lips, voice sounding weak and looking like he was about to drop dead. He had one hand stretched hand towards Izuku, who was sobbing and choking on his own spit.

“Let go of him”, Kacchan spat through teeth that were gritted in pain.

“I came such a long way to find him”, the man giggled manically, as if he couldn’t quite stop himself. Kacchan picked up his pace despite the pain and threw himself belly first on the floor, managing to grab Izuku by the ankle before he could get too further away. Izuku yelped in pain.

“I said to fucking let go!”, Kacchan took all the strength he had left to scream. He pulled Izuku’s ankle, dragging the boy closer to himself.

The villain made a pulling movement with his arm, and Izuku was yanked away from Kacchan’s grasp with a pained scream. Kacchan didn’t waste any time – he immediately threw himself back on all-fours and chased after Izuku as fast as he could, despite the pain.

“He’s such a fighter”, the villain commented with something that sounded like admiration in his voice, still slowly dragging the screaming Izuku across the floor towards him. Kacchan managed to grab the boy’s ankle once again, but the pain was making him weak, and Izuku slipped off his fingers yet again.

“Fuck!”, Kacchan screamed, dragging himself across the floor as he tried to reach Izuku, who was screaming and twisting and kicking his feet in an attempt to free himself from the invisible bond that was dragging him painfully.

“I’ve never seen someone resist my quirk as hard as he does”, the villain continued, casual and weak. “But, again, nothing like this had ever happened to me. To think I had to come all this way just to retrieve a soul…”, he giggled again. “But it’s useless to resist. You’re mine now, boy”.

“You bastard! I’ll kill you!”, Kacchan screamed at the top of his lungs.

“It’s normal to feel this pain, Bakugou-kun. You weren’t born with my quirk, after all. You aren’t supposed to have a soul attached to yours. But don’t worry”, the man smirked. “I will relieve you from this burden, now”.

“Fucking – stop him – knock him out –“

Izuku screamed, an unbearable, blinding, indescribable pain ripping through him.

“God fucking damn it – Deku!!”

“K-Kacchan”, Izuku sobbed, his fingers clinging to Kacchan’s shirt as if it was a lifeline. He was in terrible pain. “K-Kacchan, please… D-Don’t…”

“Calm down, Deku”, Kacchan ordered through gritted teeth. Izuku continued to tug at his shirt, trying to call his attention. Kacchan turned his head to look at him.

“D-Don’t let go”, Izuku pleaded. “P-Please, don’t let g-go”.

Kacchan bit his lower lip, staring down at Izuku with confident eyes.

“I’m not letting go”.

“Promise him, hero”, the villain chuckled with humor, watching the exchange and taking pleasure on the boys’ suffering. “Promise your friend you are not letting go of him”.

Kacchan glared up at the man with the fury of a thousand suns, raising one threatening, smoking hand at him.

“Don’t fucking tell me what to do, you bastard”.

The villain smirked.

Then, before Kacchan could do anything, the villain raised one hand and snapped his fingers. Izuku didn’t feel any different, but something about Kacchan’s face changed.

“I think I’ll see you around, sometime”, the villain said as he got back to his feet and walked away into the tunnel, fully recovered from his previous weakness. “But I’d rather not, really”.

Izuku sobbed pitifully, desperation and fear overwhelming him. He could feel himself becoming lighter – becoming attached to someone else.

"Kacchan… K-Kacchan…"

"I'm here".

"Kacchan, p-please, don't let… don't let go –"

"What did I fucking tell you? I'm not letting go, Deku. I've fucking got you. Ok? I've got you, just – just calm the hell down".

"P-Please –"

"I'm not letting go. I'm here. I've got you".

"Kacchan…"

"Don't you fucking trust me, shitty nerd? Didn't I just tell you I'm not letting go?"

"P-Please… Oh my god, my mom… My mom, K-Kacchan –"

"Your mom is fine. I promise you she's fine, nerd".

Izuku tried to breathe past the excruciating pain he was feeling.

"P-Please… It… It hurts…"

"I know it fucking hurts".

A twinge of hope crossed Izuku's heart.

"Y-You can feel it?"

Kacchan hesitated. If Izuku didn't know him better, he would have said he looked almost… scared.

"I can't. Not anymore"

Izuku's glassy eyes focused on him, several tears escaping through the corners. The fear he was feeling increased by a tenfold, because this couldn't be happening. If the villain took him, and if he escaped, that meant he would die in four days, and he couldn't let that happen, because… because…

If he died in four days… then One For All would die with him.

All Might's legacy. The quirk he had been trusted with. Everything he worked so hard for, and everything generations had fought to protect.

This was bigger than just him dying.

Determination filled his eyes.

Izuku immediately raised a shaking hand to his mop of a hair, grabbed a lock of his green curls, yanked it off his head and immediately shoved it into Kacchan's mouth.

Or he would have shoved it into Kacchan's mouth, if his soul hadn't chosen that exact moment to become intangible again.

Izuku phased through Kacchan's arms, and chest, and body. Kacchan could no longer touch him.

"No", Izuku sobbed, desperate, staring at his own hands – at the hair tucked into one. He desperately tried to grab Kacchan, to hold him, to cling to him, but it was useless – he was like a ghost. A real ghost, this time, phasing right through him. "No, no, no, n-no, please, Kacchan, no –"

"Deku", Kacchan whispered, eyes wide, lips parted, horrified. He tried to hold a hand to Izuku's shoulder, but it passed through. Izuku didn't even feel anything.

"Kacchan", Izuku was sobbing desperately, trying to hold Kacchan and failing. He was weak, still affected by the pain of his separation from Kacchan's soul. His fingers phased through him as if he was a hologram. "Kacchan, p-please!"

Kacchan stared at him.

"K-Kacchan!", he called urgently, desperate. He had never seen Kacchan look so lost, so… so…

Scared.

"K-K-Ka...cchan..."

"Deku –"

Before Kacchan could continue, Izuku was dragged away by an invisible force.

The villain.

He was being pulled across the floor, the pain he was feeling flaring up by a tenfold. He let out another piercing scream, but the only person who could hear him now didn't care about him. The only person who could hear him wanted him dead.

"Kacchan!", he called, desperate, craning his neck to see Kacchan kneeling at the distance, looking at the floor in front of him with shock and fear. He had no idea Izuku was being dragged away. He had no idea Izuku was no longer there, because he couldn't see him.

Izuku saw as his friends started to regain consciousness, but then the villain turned a corner and they were gone. Izuku struggled, trashing and flailing, but he couldn't get free, no matter what he did. He yelled and screamed and shouted like a feral beast, but it was to no avail.

“Let me go! Let me go! Let me go!”, he shrieked, but it only made the villain laugh.

“I love it when you guys struggle. It’s cute”, he giggled, sounding gleeful.

Rage boiled through Izuku. He was still in terrible pain and feeling weaker than he could remember, but he still forced himself to get back to his feet while the villain dragged him. He had gone through worse pain, and he wasn’t about to let this guy win so easily.

Rather than waiting to be dragged, he crossed the distance between himself and the villain and jumped at the guy, ready to deck him and give him a hard time. He wouldn’t go down without a fight after this guy ended All Might’s legacy. Even if it was all over, Izuku wanted to make him pay.

Before he could even touch the guy, however, he was frozen mid-air by a hand gesture from the villain, who turned to stare at him with something akin to pity in his eyes.

“Like I said”, he said simply, as if he thought Izuku to be pathetic. Izuku tried to move, but his limbs were frozen. “Cute”.

Then, the villain made another gesture with his hand, and before he knew it, Izuku was collapsing heavily on the floor.

The villain started dragging him again, but the feeling of being pulled, which usually came from his back, came from his neck this time, which prevented him from breathing.

He trashed and flailed again, kicking his legs to no avail while his fingers tried to ease the pressure on his throat. It was useless. The force of the bond was preventing any air from reaching his lungs, but he didn’t feel like he was about to pass out. All he felt was the pain.

“The nice thing about being a ghost is that you can’t die twice, right?”, the villain chuckled, still dragging him without sparing him another look. “All you can do is suffocate, really. I think that maybe you got to sleep a little while you were stuck with that brat, but that was just because he didn’t have the right quirk to keep you awake like I do. But don’t worry”, he chuckled again, way too happy, “I can give you a demonstration in these next four days I have with you”.

Izuku continued to desperately attempt to free himself, tears running down his face. This villain was about to torture him for four days straight, and then he would die. And no one would even know about it.

He should have forced Kacchan to write his goodbye notes.

“Serves you right for nearly killing me, don’t you think?”, the villain continued, and now the joyfulness in his tone gave way to a sinister vengeance.

Izuku continued to struggle against the whip wrapped around his neck, his lungs burning and his head feeling like it was about to explode. But the villain was right – he didn’t feel like he was about to pass out. All he felt was the pain. Burning, excruciating, eating through him –

Then something appeared in his field of vision.

It was Kacchan. Limping, and looking like he was shaking all over, but also…

Drenched in sweat…?

A tiny smile appeared on his lips. Izuku knew Kacchan wouldn't give up on him. But then realization dawned on him.

Izuku was still connected to the villain. Izuku would feel the whole thing.

More fear coursed through him. He desperately tried to think of another way, but it would be useless – Kacchan couldn't hear him. This would be the end of him, and of One For All. This would be the end of All Might.

Izuku was already dead. But if Kacchan could capture this villain and bring him to justice, then he would force himself to accept his fate a bit more easily. Maybe there was even a chance they could convince the villain to return his soul before the deadline arrived.

Do what you have to do, Kacchan.

"Howitzer –"

Izuku stopped struggling, closing his eyes. The villain snapped his head around.

"Impacto!"

He was in hell.

Fire burned his skin. His limbs. His hair, his eyes, his tongue. He couldn't move. He couldn't breathe.

He couldn't pass out, either.

Every inch of him hurt. He could feel it. Broken bones. All over. Ruptured organs. Internal bleeding. Cracked ribs.

Burnt skin.

The agony was such that he couldn't make sense of what was happening. He could see Kacchan, fallen, at the distance. He could see the villain's body, all broken and burnt, but still alive. He could feel all of it.

He couldn't fall asleep. He couldn't slip away.

All he could do was stay awake through the agony.

He saw it as All Might arrived. He saw it as the pros and the police got to the scene.

He was dragged across the floor when they put the villain in a stretcher and rolled him away. No one bothered to put him on a stretcher too.

No one could.

The pain he was feeling was so intense that the pain of being dragged didn't matter.

Things got a bit better when they hooked the villain up to pain killers, but he was forced to stay awake. It seemed he could only fall asleep if the villain wanted him to. And the villain had passed out before he could make that choice.

The pain killers did have an effect, though, but not all that much. Izuku could barely move. He didn't even manage to drag himself out of the way as he lied on the floor next to the villain's bed. Minutes became hours and hours became days, but he couldn't tell the difference. For all he knew, they could have left the sewers five minutes before, because the pain would have been the same.

He didn't even remember what it was like not feeling like every atom in his body was exploding. Was this Kacchan's legacy?

Nurses' feet phased through him on the floor. So did Recovery Girl's. It was only when All Might showed up that Izuku attempted to speak, for the first time since Kacchan's powerful howitzer.

"All… Might…", he half-croaked out, half-whined.

But the man didn't hear him.

He didn't try to speak again. It made the pain worse.

All he did was lie there. For how long, he couldn't tell. It didn't feel like it mattered, really. Soon enough, it didn't feel like anything mattered.

All that was real was the pain.

All that existed was the pain.

Existence was pain.

At some point, maybe a thousand years or one minute later, he heard someone saying that if the villain woke up before the deadline, they could put him back into his body. That sparkled something new inside Izuku, something that wasn't pain or a wish for deep sleep.

It was a nice feeling. It was different from agony. It took him longer than it should have to remember what it was called.

Hope.

If the villain's will was what was keeping him awake… Maybe Izuku could use his own will to keep the villain alive. To make him recover faster.

So he did. He wasn't sure how, but he thought of it as a blood transfusion – he used the connection that tied them together, the connection that made him feel so much pain that he forgot his own name, and he passed his vital force to the villain.

He wasn't sure why he was doing it. For all he knew, he might anticipate his death for a slight chance that this guy would survive.

But wasn't that what heroes did? Sacrificed their lives for other people? Sure, he was also doing it to save his own life, but this villain should face justice, not a death sentence. And Izuku should carry All Might's legacy, not let it die with him.

So Izuku did what he had to do.

By the time Shinsou came in with Aizawa, Izuku could barely keep his eyes open. His ghost body was translucent – more than it had ever been. He knew what that meant. He knew that he was about to die.

"Hello", Shinsou said to the villain.

The villain remained quiet.

"He's talking to you", Aizawa reprimanded, stern. "Answer the boy".

Izuku couldn't see what was going on, since he was lying on the floor and at this point, he could no longer move, too weak and fragile. But then he heard a croaked out "Hi".

Something changed in the room.

"You will immediately return Midoriya's soul to his body safe and sound, without harming him, without doing anything that will cause collateral damage now or in the future, and without doing anything that could result in his or anyone else's death", Shinsou ordered. "After that, you will break the bond between you two forever".

Nothing happened, for a while. He was still there, still in pain, still fading away as his death approached him.

And then… blackness.

It was so good. So good.

After nearly four whole days of feeling nothing but excruciating pain… The oblivion was so good… He could… Finally rest…

Or so he thought.

He woke up to white, and familiar faces, and a metallic taste on his mouth. He felt like he was being crushed. Like an elephant had stepped down on his chest. Like his body was being crushed and torn apart, like he was burning all over again.

He was so tired.

He just wanted to rest.

He thought he heard Kacchan's voice. His mom's, too. And All Might's, Todoroki's… That meant they were all safe, right? If they were there and they were speaking, that meant they were safe. That meant he could rest. He could pass out and forget about the pain…

"It has to be you, shonen. He trusted you. He needs you".

"No –"

"You're the only one of us who has his consent. If you don't take it from him, it will kill him".

"I'm losing him!"

"Bakugou shonen!"

Izuku was swallowed by black. Peaceful, painless, black.

He woke up with a harsh, loud gasp, jolting against his hospital bed.

"Midoriya shonen – ", All Might tried to tell him, placing a calming hand against his shoulder.

"Ka… cchan…", Izuku choked out.

He remembered. He remembered everything.

And it was painful. It was enlightening, and it was marvelous, but it was also so, so painful.

"N-Need… to see K-Ka… cchan…", he gasped.

“My boy…”

Izuku’s eyes rolled back and he passed out again before All Might could say anything.

When Izuku woke up again, he felt a lot better. Better enough to speak to All Might, and to learn everything that had happened while he was unconscious.

His recovery was thankfully not as complicated as he had thought it would be. He was forced to stay in the hospital for a few days, but he was also discharged sooner than he expected, under the promise to stay out of trouble and not over-exert himself.

He went from his bed straight to the waiting room of the hospital.

His friends were there. So were Kacchan’s parents.

Izuku couldn’t look them in the eye.

Kacchan’s mom looked like she wanted to speak to him, but Inko was also there with him. And she spoke to Kacchan’s parents before they could try and talk to Izuku – what they talked about, Izuku didn’t know. He was too busy writing on his notebook.

It was a brand new one. When his mom asked him what she could give him to make him feel better, back when he was still stuck to a bed, Izuku had said ‘a notebook’. But he didn’t say what it was for.

That notebook was his only focus other than Kacchan’s recovery, now. He spoke to his friends when he was spoken to; he ate when he felt hungry; he slept when he felt sleepy; but the notebook was a constant presence on his hands. He went home to shower and rest, like his doctor had instructed him, but he also came back to the waiting room every day, notebook and pen on him.

When Aizawa sensei told him, as calmly as he could, that he would not allow Izuku to see Kacchan for the sake of both of their recoveries and health, Izuku didn’t take the news very well.

He made such a scene at the hospital that his mom was forced to bring him back home – permanently. That meant no more visits, no more waiting rooms. What was the point of them, anyway? Izuku wouldn’t be allowed in.

(The fact that Aizawa sensei had announced he wouldn't allow anyone to tell Kacchan what had truly happened – about Izuku entering the rubble and breaking his arm using his quirk –, for the sake of Kacchan's health, hadn't made things all that better.)

He had arrived home and walked straight into his bedroom. He didn't close the door because he knew his mom was worried about him – he didn't want to make her feel like he was shutting her out. But he still sat down, back turned to her, and he wrote on his notebook.

And he wrote. And he wrote. And he wrote.

He kept writing. Every day. Even when classes started again and Izuku moved back to UA's dorms, he continued to write. The only times he stopped was during classes, and during the night. Sometimes, Inko called him to check on him, clearly worried, and he put on a cheery voice for her. But he kept on writing, until his fingers blistered, until his eyes were sore, until the day he got the texts.

From: Kirishima-kun

Hey, Midoriya! What's up?

From: Kirishima-kun

I hope you're feeling better

From: Kirishima-kun

I just wanted to let you know that Bakugou is being transferred to UA tomorrow morning

From: Kirishima-kun

So you can finally visit him probably in the afternoon!

From: Kirishima-kun

Let me know how you're doing later, man.

Izuku stared at his phone screen, face blank.

Kacchan was coming back. He would be allowed to see Kacchan. It had only been almost two weeks after the whole building collapse, but it was still two weeks too long. It had felt like a lifetime.

Izuku closed his notebook, his many many scribbles hidden away. Only the cape could be seen.

Everything I need to tell Kacchan #1

Chapter End Notes

"Kiksuya" means "Remember" in Lakota. That's the focus I wanted to have on this chapter - each of the boys remembering their journey and how they got where they are.

Anyway, this turned out huuuuuuge so sorry if the size bothered someone. For those who like long-ass chapters: this is your time to shine!! For those who don't and feel like this could have been shorter: I sincerely apologize.

I feel like I should clarify that I have no medical training whatsoever, all I put here comes from a lot of research. If anything doesn't make much of a sense, hmu.

"Saudade" is one of those untranslatable words that are a bit hard to explain, so I shall borrow the description from wikipedia: "Saudade is a deep emotional state of nostalgic or profound melancholic longing for an absent something or someone that one cares for and/or loves. Moreover, it often carries a repressed knowledge that the object of longing might never be had again. It is the recollection of feelings, experiences, places, or events that once brought excitement, pleasure, and well-being, which now trigger the senses and make one experience the pain of separation from those joyous sensations."

PLEASE don't be mad at Aizawa, he literally had to restrain Izuku so the paramedics could tend to Bakugou AND he has witnessed more than enough fights between those too... All he wants is his students to recover and be healthy!!

I hope you guys like it. I know I promised comfort in this one, but I didn't say it would be between Bakugou and Midoriya righttttt (wink wink nod nod). But seriously now. I feel like our Bakuboy needs to get some comfort from the other people in his life, too (especially his mom), before he faces Midoriya and everything they went through together. I know you guys were hoping we'd get to the bakudeku part of the tags already, but I want it to be special, you know? I feel like Bakugou needed to have his own sort of closure with some other people before he could fix things with Deku. His parents and his friends were also worried sick about him... They deserve a bit of time with our explodoboy.

I took so long to update this because, as everybody else, I've been freaking out and having a hard time dealing with everything that's happening in the world. On the top of that, my anxiety has gotten A LOT worse, to the point it took me twice the usual time to update this (sorry). I always try to keep updates monthly, but this time I just couldn't do it -- I had to prioritize my mental health or I'd totally lose it. My anxiety was really, really bad, and it still kind of is, but I'm getting a bit better. There was too much happening at once, and on the top of my own anxious feelings I also didn't want to divert attention from more important issues that were taking place (like protests and petitions).

Also, it pains me to say this but I'm no longer accepting follower requests on twitter. Twitter is one of the many things that has been giving me a lot of anxiety lately, so I

decided it would be better for my mental health if I made my account a bit more "private" -- that is, less people will follow me and I'll use it less often. I'm still going through the process of "softblocking" some accounts that follow me, but PLEASE, please, please, don't take this personally. It's more of a me-thing than a you-thing, no matter how cliché that sounds. But it really is. I just feel like I need some space to get my head in the right place and focus on stuff that really matters, prioritizing my mental health and not turning writing (which is a hobbie) into something stressful and so anxiety-inducing. None of you did or said anything wrong - I just need some time and some space for my own reasons.

It's nothing personal against any of you, really. Like I said there (for those who used to follow me), I might make another account that's more focused on my writing in the future. If I bring myself to do it (after I'm not feeling so stressed out over everything), I'll let you guys know so you can follow me there. Plus, if it's any consolation, I haven't been posting much about this story's updates (or anything, really) on Twitter or on Tumblr, so you won't be missing much. I just really, really need some space and I hope you all can understand this decision and respect it. This is just my anxious attempt to not freak out every time I go online, but I'm still very sorry if anyone is upset over this.

All in all, I hope you enjoyed this even though there was no reunion yet! Anxiety is a sucker, so I can't promise a faster update just yet... I'm trying to focus on getting better and dealing better with stuff, but rest assured I will not be abandoning this story. I love it too much to just quit it, and I love you guys too!

Either way, I hope this at least satisfied a bit of your bakucomfort needs ^_^ See you next time!

Chapter 27: In Which Sisyphus Finally Breaks Free From His Eternal Punishment and the World Goes Back into Tune

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Izuku was an emotional boy.

He had always been a crier. From a very early age, his mom must have noticed that. She never reprehended him or told him this behavior was something shameful, which was why Izuku grew up as a crier and would probably die a crier. When he was a kid, he was constantly made fun of by the other kids because of that. This was one of the many subjects Kacchan decided to pick up on him for.

But, as paradoxical as this might seem, Izuku rarely cried over Kacchan. At least during his non-ghost state, which was fairly most of his life. Not even when Kacchan told him to kill himself. Not even when they broke away from each other and stopped being friends.

No. Izuku was a crier, but Kacchan didn't make him cry. Not with his cruelty, not with his unjustifiable rage towards him. As sad as that may sound, Izuku was used to Kacchan's antics. Too used to them to bother crying over them – too used to them to bother doing anything, really.

He did cry *for* Kacchan, though. The incident back in training camp being one of the most vivid examples.

But, as aforementioned, this was all true for Izuku's non-ghost state. His ghost state, on the other hand, had cried quite a *lot* during the month they had spent together, probably because of the emotional imbalance of their relationship and due to the fact they were both using the other as a crutch, with no control over the intensity of their emotions or how they were shared.

That, thinking back to it, was probably exactly what Izuku had needed to wake the hell up.

This awakening had come in many shapes. The most important one, of course, being the realization that their dynamics needed to change if Izuku wanted to be happy.

He had never allowed his personal happiness to rely much on Kacchan, at least not since they were little kids who enjoyed each other's company, because if he did that his entire life would be doomed and he knew it. Instead, he had continued to admire Kacchan despite everything, trying to focus on his own goals and dreams at the same time – admiring All Might, becoming a hero, working hard to achieve that. Balance.

What Izuku had never realized he did, however, was to allow his *sadness* to rely on Kacchan. And now that he could remember his ghost-times with the boy, as well as the times that came afterwards, he could say that he had, indeed, allowed his sadness to come majorly from Kacchan.

He had never externalized that much, at least not until he was literally bodyless. Not until he was confronted with his pent-up feeling being maximized, not until he had to feel what Kacchan felt. And waking up after all that, with no memory of what had happened but a noticeable change in their dynamics, taught Izuku something he would have never learned otherwise, in any other situation.

Kacchan was dumb.

Ok, clarifying: Kacchan wasn't *dumb*. He was, in fact, one of the smartest people Izuku knew. But he had no idea how to handle his feelings – Izuku's literal ghost could confirm that –, he had a hard time admitting that – per his ghost's certification – and his emotions were so complex and mixed up that they became almost homogeneous.

Izuku knew Kacchan was going to therapy now, and that he was probably learning how to deal with all that. But what Izuku also knew was that he couldn't risk it, this time.

He needed to be blunt, straightforward and as clear as he could be. If he didn't do that, chances were Kacchan would misinterpret him again and they would enter that endless cycle of fighting for what would feel like the millionth time.

No, Izuku needed to go straight to the point. No space for doubts or misunderstandings that ended in them screaming at each other – especially because Aizawa sensei had promised him a very painful punishment if that happened while Kacchan was still in Recovery Girl's medical bay.

Izuku gripped his notebook, knuckles going white. He realized his jaw was stiff and tried to loosen it up, but it was to no avail. He was too tense. Too anxious. His foot tapped unrhythmically against the floor while he sat at the waiting area, leg bouncing up and down to reveal his nervousness. Aizawa sensei had gone in first, to make sure Kacchan was doing ok after his first night back at U.A. grounds, and Izuku was left outside with several threats that he didn't want to reach the end of.

It felt like an eternity, to wait like that. It felt like an eternity since he last saw Kacchan alive and well.

Everything else felt like a nightmare.

Even if his teachers, his friends, and some nurses reassured them that Kacchan would be fine; even if Izuku believed them, he still found it hard to just… sit still and not worry about him. He found it hard not to think about Kacchan's lifeless body being reanimated by Kaminari, he found it hard to forget about his fear and his panic over the possibility he would never get to talk to Kacchan again.

And when he managed to forget about that, as improbable as that could sound, all he could remember was his own pain – the days of living hell he spent while glued to that villain, the sensation of giving his life to save someone who wanted nothing other than hurting him and his friends. And that made him scared.

Izuku didn't know of what, exactly, because he could say he had his fair share of villains and all of them were enough to fuel his nightmares for years. He had also almost died at the hands of Shigaraki, and Stain, and Overhaul. Even the Muscular guy had been creepy enough and almost crushed him to death.

The door to Kacchan's room opened, breaking him away from his thoughts. His head immediately shot up from his open notebook, his hand stopped writing notes and his leg stopped bouncing. For a moment, the whole world was resumed to one thing: the look in Aizawa sensei's face and what it told him.

Aizawa stared at him for an analytical moment before stepping out of the room and closing the door behind him. Izuku tried, subtly, to crane his neck and look for a sneak peek of Kacchan from the distance, but he didn't quite manage to see anything before the door was blocking his vision. His eyes found his teacher again.

Aizawa stayed where he was, arms crossed loosely above his chest and tired eyes fixed on him. His back was resting against the door to the room as if he was a guard, trying to decide whether or not he would allow his student in.

A long time passed with neither of them saying anything, and before he knew it, Izuku's leg was back to bouncing. He was so nervous he didn't even realize it, hands closing his notebook and gripping it even harder. His eyes were fixed on Aizawa sensei's, the only other person in that waiting room, and his teeth were biting down on his lower lip, hard enough to bruise, because he needed to know – he needed to see Kacchan, and to talk to him, and to see he was ok and that he would be –

"Your face looks green".

Izuku swallowed dry, nauseous. He lowered his eyes in shame.

"I – I'm just nervous, sensei", he admitted, voice trembling a bit. He mentally kicked himself for that.

Aizawa sighed, sagging against the closed door. A few moments passed; his eyes fixed on Izuku.

"And are you ready for this?"

Izuku's head shot up again like it had done on the first time, frowning slightly in anticipation.

"Yes", he replied with no hesitance, even if his voice was still shaky. "I'm – I'm ready".

Aizawa continued to study him, silent. Izuku swallowed dry again, getting to his feet.

"C-Can I –", he opened and closed his mouth. "Can I go in?"

Aizawa didn't move – didn't even blink. He offered nothing as a reaction, still studying Izuku as if he was being evaluated on his finals.

"I – I mean, I was told I could –"

“You can go in”, Aizawa offered. Before Izuku could offer him a beaming smile and an excited reaction, he added: “*But* – there are some things you need to know first”.

Izuku tried to tone down his anxiety by nodding emphatically at his teacher and following him when he walked past him to take a seat. Once they were both sitting side by side, turned to each other, Aizawa continued.

“Bakugou is very debilitated. As you know, he hasn’t received any visitors other than his parents and I in several days, so he isn’t… used to staying awake during conversations. I’m sure he’ll make an effort for you” (Izuku tried not to blush), “but don’t let him overwork himself. It’s crucial he rests as much as he can so he can make a full recovery”.

Izuku nodded obediently.

“He’s also very weak. His injury was very grave, it’s not something you can get over with in a couple of days. He’ll need assistance and medication for a while. As someone who was stuck in a bed for quite a while, I’m sure you can relate to what he’s feeling”.

Izuku nodded again, serious.

“I’m also sure I can trust you to handle him while he’s like this. We both know how proud he is and how defensive he gets when he’s with you, so please avoid bringing up this subject”.

“Of course”, Izuku said.

“Finally”, Aizawa added. “We haven’t told him about what you did”.

Izuku blinked.

“What I… did?”

“About your interference”, Aizawa clarified, stern. “How you ran into a potentially deadly fallen building to rescue him, and how you were the one who kept him alive and called for help”.

Izuku felt the blood drain from his face. If he had looked green before, he certainly looked grey now.

“He doesn’t… He doesn’t remember?”, he swallowed dry, stomach twisting in fear .

Aizawa shook his head.

“We told him about Kaminari and he recalls flashes, but he doesn’t know what you did. It was my instruction that no one told him about that yet”.

Izuku frowned, suddenly angry. He remembered very well what had happened last time secrets were kept from him and Kacchan – he had almost died and lived four days of pure hell.

“Why?”, he asked, a bit disrespectfully. “Why would you keep secrets from him?”

“Calm down”, Aizawa told him in a scolding tone. “You’re in no position to reprehend me, Midoriya. I didn’t tell him because his status was critical, and I didn’t want him to hurt himself by worrying over you”.

The anger seeped off him like steam and Izuku’s whole posture sagged in shame and guilt. He bowed his head and tightened his hands into fists, unable to apologize but unwilling to compromise his chance to see Kacchan.

“Do I have to pretend that didn’t happen, either?”, he asked, tone not accusing but resigned. Aizawa huffed.

“He’s starting to remember more things”, he explained. “It’s only a matter of time before he remembers something deeper and starts asking questions”.

Izuku faced his teacher again, eyes wide.

“So *I’ll* have to tell him?!”

Aizawa nodded. Izuku frowned harder.

“I can’t start a fight with him, but I have to tell him something that is bound to start a fight?!”

His teacher sighed.

“There’s no easy way to let him know what happened. I figured that letting you tell him yourself would be the best choice”.

“Sensei –“

“If I did it, he would be more nervous”, Aizawa interrupted him. “As well as your friends. It’s better if he hears it from you, while he can see that you are well and alive”.

Izuku’s mouth opened and closed, trying to come up with arguments for that. Eventually, he was forced to admit Aizawa sensei was right. Kacchan would either remember or learn what happened eventually – it would be better if that happened while he could see Izuku was alive and well, instead of hearing from anybody else.

The talk was still bound to result in a fight, though, which was why Izuku found himself saying:

“But sensei, even if he doesn’t get as nervous, how can I tell him that without it ending in a fight –“

“What you did was your decision, Midoriya”, Aizawa cut him off sternly. “And you are yet to face the proper consequences for that, but you should own it. However –“, he added before his student could protest. “Rest assured I won’t ban you from visiting if you two fight over that. *Only* if you fight over that, do you understand? If you two yell at each other for any other reason, I will not be so lenient”.

Izuku frowned again.

“B-But how will you know what caused our fight? If – I-If we fight, of course”.

Aizawa narrowed his eyes.

“Are you saying you would lie to your sensei about that?”

Izuku’s eyes immediately widened and he raised his hands in a surrendering gesture.

“No, n-no, of course not!”, he stuttered, blushing. “I w-would never do that, sensei”.

Aizawa huffed.

“Good”, he said sternly. “Tell me again what you needed to know before you go in”.

Izuku swallowed dry, lowering his arms and gripping his notebook with both hands.

“Not letting Kacchan overwork because he needs to sleep”, he listed. “Not mentioning that he’s weak or debilitated because of his pride. Not fighting him unless it’s about how I saved him”.

“I wouldn’t phrase it like that”, Aizawa sighed. “You’re not supposed to fight him, at all”.

“I – … I –“

“*But* – if he gets angry when you mention that”, Aizawa continued. “You won’t be punished”.

Izuku nodded.

“*H-Hai*”.

Aizawa studied him for a few more moments.

“Are you good to go in?”, he raised an eyebrow.

Izuku realized his leg had gone back to bouncing. He stopped it before taking a deep breath and nodding slowly at his teacher.

“Yes, sensei”, he said, sounding as calm as he possibly could.

Aizawa nodded back, getting back to his feet. Izuku followed him.

“I’ll wait outside”, he announced, gripping the door handle. Izuku’s heart leaped and started to speed up. “And I’ll go inside if I hear shouting”.

Izuku swallowed again, nodding.

“And Midoriya”, he added seriously.

“Yes, sensei?”

Aizawa gazed at him.

“Take it easy on him”, he advised. “Don’t be scared if he doesn’t seem like himself. He’s still recovering”.

Izuku tried his best not to frown in worry, nodding again instead. He was so eager to see Kacchan that all these advices were only making him more nervous. *What would he find in there?*

He tightened his lips with a determined look on his face and twisted the doorknob, trying to make himself ready to find out.

When Izuku entered the room, Kacchan was… normal.

Well. For starters, Kacchan was half-sitting, half-lying down on the bed, but his eyes were alert and his posture was tense. He was watching Izuku with attention as he entered the room, as if expecting him, and his posture sagged as soon as he took Izuku in, as if relieved. Izuku tried his best not to blush at this realization, but he supposed he wasn’t so lucky, since his face was pale enough to make the blushing very noticeable.

He walked into the room, shoulders tense and eyes fixed on Kacchan. Taking him in. Reading him. Noticing how his chest was rising and falling consistently, how his sharp eyes were sustaining his gaze. The tension inside the room was nearly palpable at this point, and with each step Izuku felt it grow. But he also couldn’t help but to feel relieved to see Kacchan alive.

He didn’t know why Aizawa had been so insistent with his warnings about Kacchan’s state, because he seemed to be very aware and awake – at least more so than he had been last time Izuku saw him.

Izuku stopped in front of Kacchan’s bed, at his feet. Kacchan continued to stare at him, silent and Izuku stared back, at a loss for words.

Silence.

Izuku’s grip on his notebook became tighter. Everything he wanted to say was written and spelled out on those pages, but he couldn’t simply open the notebook and read them aloud to Kacchan.

…Could he?

No. He had to say something first, he needed to ask how Kacchan was doing, how he was faring up, if he was in any pain, if he needed anything. He *needed* to say something, because he had walked into that room in silence and neither of them had said anything so far.

Izuku lowered his head, breaking eye contact to gather up strength. Because he needed to be strong; it was taking him every ounce of self-control not to burst into tears. Because last time he saw Kacchan, he had been dying and covered in blood. Now, he was… here. Still recovering, still weakened, but he seemed to be fine. Or as fine as he could be, given the circumstances.

Izuku took in a shaky breath before raising his chin and meeting Kacchan's eyes again. Two crimson irises were staring back at him, enigmatic – a contrast to the one-eyed hazy gaze the dying Kacchan had offered him, due to his other eye that had been swollen shut.

Kacchan was silent, as if he had decided Izuku was going to do the talking today. No snarky comment or angry demands, which was uncharacteristic to say the least. *Is this what Aizawa sensei was talking about?*

Izuku took in another shaky breath, worrying at his lower lip for a moment.

"H-How are you?"

Kacchan blinked at him, as if he hadn't been expecting that question. He glanced at his arms, which were still enveloped by casts, before meeting Izuku's eyes again and narrowing them.

"Whatcha think?", he said, and to Izuku's surprise his voice wasn't weak or small. It sounded normal and healthy, even if it was a bit raspier than usual.

"I'm –", Izuku swallowed dry, not sure of what he wanted to say. "I'm sorry".

A pause.

"Not your fault", Kacchan said. And then he went back to the silent-staring.

Izuku lowered his head again.

"Are you – Are you in any pain?", he asked, staring at his own feet. He heard Kacchan scoff.

"It's better now. They still have me hooked to the pain meds, so I don't have much to complain about".

"That's a first", Izuku chuckled out, before frowning and mentally kicking himself. "No, sorry. I didn't mean it like that".

Kacchan rolled his eyes, but Izuku didn't see it.

"Well, you didn't tell any lies".

Izuku bit his lower lip.

He raised his eyes to look at Kacchan again, fearful. He seemed ok, but it could be an act – he knew how Kacchan was when it came to his own image. He was too proud to ever admit he needed something, too proud not to pretend he was ok, even when he wasn't. plus, he was still going through a thorough recovery process, and any setback could be very harmful to him. Izuku didn't want to cause any setbacks. He didn't want to do anything that could potentially harm Kacchan, but he couldn't keep his thoughts to himself any longer either.

He needed to say stuff. So much stuff. Most of all, stuff Kacchan needed to hear.

He also needed to say stuff Kacchan didn't need to hear, but he would cross that bridge when he came to it.

"Why are you giving me that look?", Kacchan asked, sounding mildly annoyed for once. Izuku's blush deepened.

"W-What look?", he asked, defensive.

"I don't know", Kacchan shrugged, looking suspicious. "But it's weird".

Izuku closed his eyes for a moment, embarrassed.

"Sorry".

"Stop apologizing".

"Sorry for apologizing".

A sigh.

"Seriously, Deku?"

Izuku lowered his head again. His brain was starting to race once more, but he couldn't open the notebook and start writing his thoughts down like he had been doing for the past week. He couldn't allow himself to drift along with his thoughts, either – he needed to stay focused on the present: on his conversation with Kacchan. He needed to focus on what he had to say.

"I just –", a pause. "I just got a lot in my mind right now".

A scoff.

"You think I don't? I've been lying in bed doing nothing all day for over a week now".

Izuku looked at him. He had imagined that Kacchan was about to go crazy with the amount of spare time he had, but he had never expected to hear him admit that.

" – But that has also given me a lot of time to think", Kacchan continued. "About some stuff".

Izuku eyed him.

“About… some stuff?”

Kacchan nodded.

“I think I can say the same about you, if that notebook you’ve got there is what I think it is”.

Izuku stared at the notebook he was holding, mouth opening and closing.

“I – How –“

“We know each other since we were brats”, Kacchan offered. “When you think, you write. When you overthink, you overwrite. It’s what you do”.

Izuku blushed one more time. Sometimes, he forgot how well Kacchan knew him, just as well as he knew Kacchan – even if Kacchan also got him wrong a lot of times.

He walked up from the foot of the bed towards the chair sitting next to Kacchan’s head, notebook tight on his grip and free hand flexing in and out of a fist. Kacchan watched him.

“You’re right”, Izuku said. “I did write some of my thoughts”.

“Some of them”, Kacchan repeated in a deadpan.

“Some of them, yeah”, Izuku nodded. “And I wanted to go over them with you, if you don’t mind. Not all of them at once, of course, because you’re still recovering and I don’t want to end up causing any kind of setback on that –“

“Deku”.

“Yeah?”

“Just tell me what you need to tell me. Don’t you dare sugarcoat me because I’m – like this”.

Izuku held his breath. He averted his gaze from Kacchan for a moment.

“I can’t do it all at once”, he admitted. “Not all of it”.

Kacchan just stared at him. He stared back, eyes sincere.

“I have to do it slowly”, he continued. “If not for your sake, then for mine”.

Kacchan stared for a few more instants before he nodded.

“All right”, he said, weirdly comprehensive and not his usual yelling form, which set off all sorts of red alerts inside Izuku’s brain.

“You’re… Not mad about it?”, he frowned, suspicious and worried. Kacchan rolled his eyes.

“Deku, take a good hard look at me”, he said, slightly annoyed. “I’m bored out of my damn mind and I can’t even drink a glass of water without someone else helping me because of my damn arms. If you really wrote a notebook-worth of subjects you want to discuss and you

want to take it slowly, then go ahead. If we do this bit by bit at least you'll keep me entertained for more than one day".

Izuku blinked at him.

"O…k", he complied, shifting the notebook from hand to hand. Kacchan had a point, but it was still weird to hear him so compliant. Izuku couldn't say he had been expecting this. "So, how do you want to do this?"

Kacchan scoffed.

"Tch. You tell me, you're the one with the notes".

Izuku narrowed his eyes at him in suspicion.

"Ok, what's wrong?"

Kacchan glared.

"What are you talking about?"

"Something's off", Izuku said bluntly. "But I can't figure out what it is".

"Well, welcome to my life", Kacchan snorted. "That's everyday with you".

Izuku gave him a look.

"That's not true".

"Are we going back to arguing already?", Kacchan rolled his eyes.

Izuku halted.

"No", he said decisively. "No, we're not arguing today".

It was Kacchan's turn to give Izuku a look.

"I doubt it".

"You shouldn't. Because whenever I realize we're about to start arguing I'm going to take a step back and go out for some air before we actually get to it", he announced. That was one of the things he had written down on his notebook.

Kacchan scoffed.

"You're gonna be taking a lot of steps back then", he muttered.

"If that becomes necessary, then yes".

Another scoff. Then, silence.

“So?”, Kacchan asked.

“You’re ok with this?”, Izuku asked back, still suspicious about all that compliance.

“What the fuck am I going to do if I’m not ok with this?”, Kacchan demanded grumpily. “I can’t exactly hold you by the hand and keep you from going out if that’s what you want”.

Izuku stared at him. It felt like something unexpected, to see Kacchan acting like that, when so little time ago they had argued and argued and argued over very similar subjects. Izuku felt like Kacchan was supposed to tell him to go to hell or something like that, but he didn’t – he just kept staring at Izuku with expectation barely hidden in his intense crimson eyes.

Izuku took in a shaky breath, gripping the notebook.

“Fine”, he swallowed. “Can we get to it?”

“Go ahead”, Kacchan shrugged.

Izuku sat down on the chair by the bed and stared at Kacchan for a few more moments before awkwardly opening his notebook.

“Ok”, he said, more to himself than to Kacchan, trying to figure out how to begin.

“Are you gonna read?”

“What?”

“Are you gonna read everything you wrote down?”

A pause.

“No”.

“You were gonna”.

“No, I wasn’t”.

A sigh.

“Just get this over with already, Deku. I have stuff I want to say, too”.

Izuku looked at him.

“You do?”

Kacchan rolled his eyes.

“Yeah”.

“Do you… want to go first, or…?”

“I ain’t going first”, a scoff.

“That’s unusual, coming from you”.

“Shut the hell up”, a snort, but it sounded friendlier than usual. “I’m just letting you go first because you have a whole ass notebook. I want to get it out of the way”.

Izuku gripped the pages tighter. At least that sounded a bit more like the Kacchan he knew ~~(and loved)~~.

“Fine. Ok”.

“Whenever you’re ready”, a mocking comment.

Izuku took another deep breath.

“So”, he cleared his throat. “First of all, we need to talk about what happened”.

“Ok”.

“About how the… the building fell, and everything. And things that happened after that. Would you be ok with that?”

A pause.

“Yeah”.

“You sure?”

“Yeah”, Kacchan nodded. “Go ahead”.

Izuku shifted on his seat.

“Ok. So, um. I need to tell you something, and I need you to not be mad about it”.

“Because you’re gonna storm out if I do?”

“I’ll have to walk away for a bit until you cool down, yes”, he nodded.

Kacchan sniffed.

“Fine”.

“Ok”.

Silence.

“So…? You planning on doing it today, or…?”

“IwentafteryouwhileyouwereburiedbytherubbleandIsortofkeptyoualiveuntilhelparrived”.

A pause.

"*What*?"

"I… went after you", Izuku swallowed. "After the building fell on you. I broke the police's barricade and climbed my way into the building to find you. And I stayed with you until help arrived. The whole structure started to collapse on us while we were getting you out, so I – I used my quirk to smash the rubble away. I came to the hospital with you, but – Kacchan?"

Kacchan was frowning deeply, not in anger but in confusion.

"What do you mean you used your quirk?"

Oh, right, that. That was definitely not the subject Izuku wanted to start with.

"Yes, you probably don't remember but I have my quirk back, we'll get to that –"

"What do you *mean* you have your quirk back? How?"

Izuku sighed.

"I'll – I'll explain", he promised. "But there's stuff I wanted to discuss first".

"Then why did you start with that?"

"I forgot you forgot!"

"Well, then explain!"

"I will, but there's stuff I want to talk about first!"

"For fuck's sake!"

"*Sorry*!"

A pause. They were both breathing heavily.

"So, um. I wanted to get that out of the way".

"You did".

"And you're not mad about it?"

Kacchan rolled his eyes.

"Are you gonna keep asking that every time you say something slightly risky?"

Izuku sustained his gaze.

"I just want to make sure you're not holding on to any negative emotion before we go on".

Kacchan scoffed.

“Well, I can remember some flashes of you and the rubble, so it actually makes sense you were there with me. I can’t remember much else, though, and I’m not mad because you’re obviously fine, so whatever reason I had to freak out is now over. It’s not like you’re hurt, right?”

“No, I’m not”, Izuku provided. “I did break my arm when I smashed. *But* –“, he added quickly before Kacchan could protest. “It’s fine now! I’m fine!”

Kacchan stared at him through narrowed eyes, but he didn’t say anything – no scolding, no grumpy retort, no angry remark. Which was weird. He should be at least ironizing him, shouldn’t he?

Izuku stared at him with concern. It seemed that the time Kacchan had taken to think things through had done him some good, after all, even if weirded Izuku out. It also seemed like he was more honest than usual, which could be a side effect of the medicine he was under.

“Ok”, Izuku sniffed. “So now that’s out of the way –“

“You’re gonna tell me how you got your quirk back?”

“ – I’m gonna go back a little”.

An eyeroll.

“Back to the time we were kids”.

“*That* far?”

“Yes”.

“*Ugh*. At least tell me if you have your damn memories back, now”.

“I do”, Izuku nodded.

“Great. Were you going to mention that or…?”

“We’ll get there eventually”, Izuku pointed out sternly. “So”, he cleared his throat again. “You hated me. Right?”

Kacchan thought for a little.

“Not when we were brats”, he admitted. “That came later. When we were kids, I liked having you around. You were always chasing after me and giving me praise”.

Izuku nodded.

“The hatred came when you found out I was quirkless, right?”

Kacchan thought more.

“Nah”, he shook his head. “You being quirkless just made me feel even better about myself”.

Izuku shifted his weight from foot to foot.

“So when did you start hating me?”

Kacchan pondered.

“I don’t know. It just happened one day”.

“It just *happened*?”, Izuku snorted.

“Yeah”, Kacchan shrugged. “One day I realized I couldn’t stand your face anymore. I didn’t put much thought into it. It was more of a feeling”.

Izuku’s lips formed a thin line. He looked away for a moment before lowering his head and looking at Kacchan again.

“Yeah, you see, I don’t think that’s it”.

“What?”

“I don’t think that’s it”, he shook his head. “I don’t think you actually hated me”.

Kacchan stared at him in silence, waiting for him to continue.

“I mean, well, yes, you *had* to hate me to do those things you did, but I think – I think you cared”.

Silence. Izuku’s eyes were fixed on Kacchan’s.

“I think you *always* cared”.

“Deku –“

“No, hear me out –“

“Deku, the shit I did to you –“

“Hear me *out* –“

“That wasn’t because I cared –“

“Let me explain –“

“And we’ve gone over this and I thought you had already forgiven me –“

“Let me *explain*”, Izuku emphasized. “I’m not saying you cared about me. I’m saying you cared what I thought”.

Kacchan stared at him. There was an unpleasant look on his face, as if he was caught between a rock and a hard place.

“You cared what I thought about you, even if I was just some quirkless kid who used to be friends with you. And I think you hated how much my opinion mattered to you, especially because you were always boasting about not caring what anyone thought”.

Kacchan looked away in silence, a serious yet pensive look on his face.

“Do you agree with me? Be honest”.

Kacchan glared at him.

“I’m always honest”.

“Not always”, Izuku gave him a look.

“Tch”, Kacchan clicked his tongue, glaring away.

A pause.

“I don’t think that’s it”, he admitted eventually. “I mean, I did care what you thought and it pissed me off that I did. But I didn’t hate you because of that”.

Izuku kept looking at him. Kacchan met his eyes.

“I hated you because I was a different person. Because I used to think people were no better than their quirks were, I used to think quirks were the only valuable thing to consider. I used to believe that not having a quirk meant having no use to society, and the fact that you behaved as if you were my equal even though you were quirkless pissed me off. Soon enough *everything* you did or said pissed me off, and then not even your constant praise made up for the irritation. I only cared what you thought because I wanted you to know your place”.

Izuku stared at him for a few more moments before looking down, at his own feet.

“But you don’t hate me anymore”, it was an affirmation.

A pause.

“No”.

“And you don’t think like that anymore”.

“You know I don’t”.

“Right. Um, ok”.

An awkward silence. Izuku fiddled with his notes, trying to figure out how to continue.

“There’s – um, there’s still a lot I want to say to you, and I can’t say everything all at once and today, so the next big topic is – erm. It’s One For All”.

“Which you mysteriously got back from me with no explanation”.

“Yes – I’ll get to that in a moment”, Izuku promised. “But first I want to go over something more important, and for that I’m grateful you don’t hate me anymore otherwise this would be really awkward”.

“Just say what you mean, nerd”, Kacchan snorted, trying to pretend he wasn’t feeling wary.

Izuku’s mouth opened and closed.

“When – When a holder transfers One For All”, he begun, mouth dry. “Their – essence, or something like that – stays with the quirk. It’s passed along with it. Right?”

“Right”.

“Well”, Izuku swallowed. “That means the previous holder can still use the quirk even after it’s passed on. All Might fought All For One using only the embers after he passed it on to me, for example”.

“So you’re saying –“

“I think you’ll still be able to use it”, Izuku continued before Kacchan could finish. “Later. When you’re better”.

Silence.

“I don’t want it –”

“I know you don’t”.

A pause.

“I don’t *need* it”.

“I *know* you don’t –“

“But now I’m stuck with it?”

A sigh.

“Listen – I’m sorry. About that. But that’s not all”.

Kacchan raised an eyebrow. Izuku sighed, his shoulders sagging.

“Maybe I should remind you not to freak out for the sake of your recovery –“

“All this stalling is making me freak out, so unless you want a blanket wrapped around your throat –“

“That’s not all”, Izuku repeated. “I mean. When a holder passes One For All on, they also… please don’t freak out – but they also pass on their own quirk”.

Kacchan's face was blank for a second, and then it became pale, as if all blood had been drained from it out of a sudden. His eyes were wide with unmistakable fear.

"Are – Are you saying I'm –"

"Kacchan –"

"I'm – I'm quirkless? Is that what you're saying?"

It was Izuku's turn to go pale. He hadn't even considered that possibility.

"N-No", he said quickly, nervous. "I mean, I don't know, but I wouldn't think so –"

Before he could continue, Kacchan raised one of his casted hands and stared at it. In less than a second, the cast cracked with a sharp pop, and Kacchan winced in pain.

He had used his quirk, even with his hand broken – just to check if he still had it.

"Kacchan!", Izuku let go of his notebook and jumped at him, grabbing his now exposed broken hand. Kacchan held his breath, but didn't flinch away. "What on earth were you thinking?!"

"I needed to know", Kacchan offered simply, a grimace painting his now sweaty face. "I just needed to know, Deku".

"I didn't mean you were quirkless!", Izuku added, nervous but relieved that the theory had been so quickly proven wrong. He was still holding Kacchan's broken hand. "You shouldn't have done that!"

"At least my quirk's still here", he groaned, now looking slightly green. Izuku immediately reached forward and pressed the buzzer to call a nurse.

"Yeah, and now your hand is worse! You could have waited until it was healed –"

"I just needed to know, dammit!"

"So much for saying you don't think quirks are everything!"

"It's easier said than done; you spent your whole life without one!"

"Yeah, so I know its value more than anyone!"

"Well, and I know –"

"What is going on in here? Midoriya?", it was Aizawa sensei, accompanied by a nurse. They had just arrived, and the nurse rushed to Kacchan's side at the sight of his hand. Aizawa seemed to have spotted her going in and followed her.

"Sensei", Izuku said, eyes darting between Kacchan's broken hand and his teacher, unsure of what to say. "I – I –"

“You, me, out”, Aizawa ordered simply. “Bakugou, don’t do anything stupid until I come back”.

“Wait –“, Kacchan tried to protest, but was stopped by a wince as the nurse checked on his broken hand.

“Midoriya. Out. *Now*”, the man instructed again in a tone that left no place for a discussion.

Izuku spared Kacchan one final apologetic look before stepping out after his teacher.

“You care to explain to me how I left you alone with Bakugou for a few minutes and he ended up re-breaking his hand?”

“Sensei, I can explain –“

“I *hope* you can”.

“I was just – we were talking about quirks, and he was worried he couldn’t use his anymore –“

“So he decides to throw away his recovery process and break his own hand?”

“Y-Yes – I couldn’t stop him, I’m sorry –“

“Midoriya”, Aizawa cut him off sternly. “I wasn’t born yesterday. I know you must have said something important for Bakugou to react like that, and I want to know what it was”.

But Izuku couldn’t tell his teacher, not without breaking his promise to All Might and revealing One For All’s secret. Which meant he would have to lie.

“W-We were just talking about quirks”.

“Ok. Why?”

“Why?”

“Yes. Why were you talking about quirks?”

“Well – I – I started talking about how I used mine back at the debris and one subject brought another, and then he was afraid he wouldn’t be able to use his quirk anymore and he freaked out. I swear I didn’t know what he would do –“

Aizawa sighed deeply, pinching the bridge of his nose between two fingers. Izuku took this chance to breathe in and try to calm down – try to think of a way of getting back inside with Kacchan.

“Why do I have a feeling you’re about to ask me to go back in?”

“Sensei –“

“Midoriya. This is very serious”.

Izuku swallowed dry, mouth opening and closing.

“I – I know –“

“I think you and Bakugou need a break”.

“Sensei –“

“I mean it, Midoriya. He broke his own hand after talking to you. There’s no way you’re going back in right now. Come back tomorrow”.

“But –“

“Tomorrow”, Aizawa interrupted him. “And I’ll see what I think of it”.

Izuku lowered his head, biting at his lower lip. His hands were tightened into fists.

“Yes, sir”, he gave in eventually, before taking a seat on the waiting chair.

Aizawa eyed him.

“Go back to your room”, the teacher instructed. “You need to cool off, too”.

Izuku wanted to argue – he wanted to stay there the whole night, if anything – but he knew it was a lost cause. If he tried to stay, he might make things even worse on his side. So instead of offering a response, he stood up, bowed Aizawa his goodbye, and left.

It was only late into the night that he realized his notebook stayed behind at Kacchan’s room.

“So”.

“So”.

Silence.

“Does… Your hand hurt?”

“Not really. I’m still on those damn meds”.

“Oh”.

“Yeah”.

Silence.

“You forgot your notebook here”.

“I – I know”.

“I found that surprising”.

“Oh?”

“You’re always clingy with this type of thing”.

“Yeah – I suppose I am”.

More silence.

“Did you read it?”

“Tch”.

A pause.

“No”.

“Why not?”

“I figured you’d get pissed if I did”.

Izuku’s chest felt warm. Kacchan had taken his feelings into consideration? That was new.

(Except it wasn’t, not really.)

“Can we start over?”

“Hm?”

“Aizawa sensei was very strict about letting me back in again”.

“I wonder how that conversation went”.

“He nearly stopped me from coming back in, but he gave me one more chance. So I was thinking we could start over, go easier this time. Hopefully not break any limbs. Or else I will be kicked out of here, for good this time”.

“Tch”.

“So?”

A pause.

“Fine.”

“Good. Ok”.

Silence.

“So… I have One For All back”.

“Uh huh”.

“You passed it back to me”.

“Yep”.

“You *really* didn’t read the notebook?”

Kacchan rolled his eyes.

“I’m telling you I didn’t”.

“It’s just –“, Izuku hesitated. “I don’t know”.

“You have a notebook worth of subjects to discuss but you *don’t know*?”

Izuku blinked.

“Good idea”, he said, reaching out and grabbing the notebook from where it was sitting at Kacchan’s nightstand.

He opened it, eyes traveling through the pages. It took him a while to get his thoughts into the right tracks again.

“So, all right”, he cleared his throat, finger pointing at one of his notes. “Quirks. You might still have mine”.

“Which *sucks*”.

“You don’t have to use it, Kacchan”.

“And I won’t. But I still wish I didn’t have it”.

“Well, I’m sorry. But that wasn’t even my main point”.

“Well, get to it, then”, a scoff. “You think I’ve got all day?”

Izuku looked at him, trying to figure out whether it was a joke or a serious statement. Kacchan’s face was unreadable.

“My point is… I might have yours, too”.

A blank face.

“Say what now?”

“Your quirk”, Izuku swallowed dry. “You might have passed it on to me – accidentally, and, uh, hypothetically. I haven’t tried it yet”.

Silence.

Kacchan was staring at his own hands, which were resting above his lap. Izuku shifted his weight from foot to foot.

“Um, how –“, he started, awkward. “How does that make you feel?”

Kacchan lifted his eyes to look at him.

A pause.

“I don’t know”, he said with honesty.

“Oh”.

“I… I have to think about it”.

Izuku frowned.

“Aren’t you upset?”, he asked. Kacchan wasn’t the type to take some time and think about it, he was more of a explode-first-ask-questions-later type of person. The answer was uncharacteristic of him, but Kacchan simply looked to the side uncomfortably and shrugged.

“I don’t know what to think, Deku. You’re saying you might have my quirk now, and I have no idea how I’m supposed to feel about that. I didn’t even know that was a possibility”.

“Me neither”, Izuku rushed to explain. “Just to be clear with you. All those months I was waiting for you to give my quirk back, it never crossed my mind. Not until a week ago”.

“What does All Might think?”

“He thinks… He thinks it’s possible”, Izuku shrugged. “And I figured I should be the one to tell you”.

“Well, there aren’t a lot of options there”, Kacchan scoffed. “It was either you or All Might”.

“Would you rather it was All Might?”, Izuku asked with curiosity.

Kacchan stared at him for a moment.

“Nah. That would only make things more awkward”.

“Do you think things are awkward right now?”

“Well, I ain’t exactly super comfortable with the idea that you have my quirk, but I’m pretty sure hearing All Might say that would make me react differently”.

“Why?”

“Hm?”

“Why would you react differently?”

Kacchan hesitated.

“Not sure I want to tell you”.

“*Kacchan*”.

“What? You should be glad I’m not losing my shit all over you”.

“Well, I am glad”, Izuku nodded. “But I think we need to be honest with each other”.

“*More* honest?”

“Honest enough”, Izuku retorted. “Because I still have some stuff to say, and it’s going to be…”

“What?”

“… Raw”.

“Raw?”

“Yes”, Izuku put his notebook down. “Because I need to ask you some questions, and you need to be super honest with me when you answer them”.

Kacchan eyed him suspiciously.

“Ok”, he said, doubtful.

“Ok”, Izuku swallowed dry. “So. You have friends”.

Kacchan seemed surprised.

“I guess so, yeah”.

“You do have friends. And you care about them”.

“O…k?”

“Don’t you?”

“Don’t I what?”

“Care about them”.

“What does that have to do with anything?”

“It has to do with the point I’m trying to make. How about this –“, he shifted his weight. “I’ll ask something, you’ll say if it’s true or false”.

“I’m not a little kid, I ain’t playing your games –“

“Kacchan”, Izuku interrupted, serious. “It’s not a game. I’m just trying to make things easier, on both of us. Please?”

Kacchan studied him, looking slightly pissed off.

“Fine”, he relented, and he looked like he wanted to cross his arms but couldn’t because of the fresh cast.

“Fine”, Izuku repeated. “So, you have friends”.

“Hm”.

“True or false?”

“True”, Kacchan rolled his eyes as if it was obvious.

“Uh huh. And you care about them”.

A pause.

“True”, a mumble.

“Good. You consider me your friend, now”.

Another eyeroll.

“True”.

“But we’re still rivals who want to become the number one hero”.

“True”, this time with no hesitation.

“Good”, Izuku nodded, shifting his weight from one foot to another. “You used to hate me before”.

“True”.

“But the month we spent together when I was a ghost changed the way you saw me”.

A pause.

“True”.

“And you started to care about me too, like you care about your friends”.

“… True”.

“Except you seem to care about me more than you care about them”.

“That’s only because you were always one sneeze away from breaking your own spine”.

“True or false, Kacchan?”

“*Fine*. True”.

Izuku nodded, eyes glued to his notebook.

“You called me quirkless back at your birthday because you were worried about me”.

“True”.

“But you do realize how wrong that was”.

A pause. Longer, this time.

“True”, Kacchan said, “But I don’t regret it”.

“You… don’t?”

“I did what I had to do to protect you”.

“And that resulted in a six-month-long fight during which neither of us talked to each other”.

“Well, yeah. But you’re still alive, right?”

“Yes, because there wasn’t any danger!”

“Except the guy who made the noise was working with the villains, dumbass”.

“Kacchan. I don’t want to fight”.

“Then don’t”.

“But you hurt my feelings back then, and then again back at the deposit room when you acted like I was just deadweight”.

A deep sigh.

“I thought we had gotten over this”.

Izuku looked away.

“I don’t think our arguments meant we were ‘getting over’ this, Kacchan”.

“Fine. You want me to apologize, right?”

Izuku met his eyes.

“Not really, no. After what happened, I understand why you did what you did. I just want to know that you understand how you’ve hurt me, so that you won’t do it again”.

Kacchan studied him.

“I understand”, he said. “And just to be clear I *am* sorry for calling you quirkless. I was just trying to –“

“Keep me safe, I know”, Izuku nodded, a small smile painting his lips. “I forgive you, Kacchan”.

Kacchan huffed, looking away as if he didn’t want to admit he was relieved to hear that.

“So, just to sum up”, Izuku said. “You care about me, and I care about you”.

“Right”.

“I might go as far as to say that you like me, now”.

A scoff.

“If you want to put it that way”.

“And we care to the point we’re willing to risk ourselves for each other”.

“Yeah, right”.

“Am I wrong?”

An eyeroll.

“No”.

A nod.

“Well”, Izuku straightened up. “I think we’re done for today”.

“Oh, is that it?”, a scoff. “Done for the day? What is this, the world’s shittiest therapy session?”

“I told you I wanted to take things slowly. I don’t want to overwork you”.

“I can handle more talking”, Kacchan protested, offended.

“I know you can”, Izuku nodded, “but you need your rest”.

“Deku”, a growl, “don’t start treating me like I’m some sort of invalid”.

“I’m not. If you’re going to be angry, then be angry at Aizawa sensei. He’s the one who made the rules. Though I don’t think you should be angry at him, if anything you should be –“

“*Deku*”.

“What?”

“Don’t start rambling on me”.

“Right. Um, I should, you know. Get going”.

“Gonna leave the notebook here again?”

“Do you want me to?”

“Well, maybe I’ll get around to reading it this time”.

“I’m taking it, then”.

“I’m just messing with ya”.

“I was going to take it anyway, Kacchan”.

“All right, suit yourself”.

A pause.

“You’re being…”

Hesitation.

“What?”

“I don’t know”.

“Spit it out”.

“You’re being uncharacteristically chill about everything”.

“Oh, am I?”

“Yes”.

“The *hell* if I am”.

“Are you trying to sound combative on purpose just to prove me wrong?”

“… No”.

A chuckle.

“Get some rest, Kacchan”, Izuku said, stepping away from the bed. “We can continue tomorrow”.

“Fine, but that’s on you. I’m not tired or anything”.

“I know you’re not”.

“Good”.

“You should still get some rest”.

“How about you don’t tell me what to do?”

“See?”

“See what?”

“You’re being chill!”

“*How* is that me being chill?”

“You said ‘how about’ instead of saying ‘don’t tell me what to do’”.

“And why the fuck does that mean I’m chill?”

“Ah, you’re back to swearing”.

“Well, yeah, if you’re gonna keep nagging at me –“

“I’m not nagging – You know what?”

“What?”

“I’m getting out of here before we start arguing. See you tomorrow, Kacchan!”

“You better kick it before I find a way to beat you up”.

Katsuki watched with fondness as the door closed behind Izuku.

“How is his progress?”, Aizawa asked.

“Slow, but steady”, the nurse replied. “He’s still having trouble standing up on his own, but it’s only a matter of time before he’s back on his feet. Quite literally. He’s responding well to the anxiety medication we’ve been giving him”.

“I see. Keep me updated, will you?”

“I will”.

A pause.

“Will you tell him?”

“About what?”

“The medication”.

A sigh.

“I will, at some point. When he’s stronger”.

“He sounds like a stubborn one. You think he will refuse the treatment if he knows?”

“I think he’s not even aware he needs it”.

“I understand”.

“You do?”

“It’s common for patients to get stuck in the denial stage for a while. But in cases as extreme as his was, medication is not something to be taken for granted”.

“I agree”.

“I’m sure you two will find a way”.

“I hope we do. Otherwise…”

“Otherwise what?”

“Otherwise I’ll have to play dirty”.

“Oh”.

Aizawa looked away.

“Thank you. For everything, including your patience”.

“You’re quite welcome, Mr. Aizawa”.

“You’re being weird”.

“What?! Why?!”

“I don’t know. But you’re acting weird”.

“Kacchan, I just got here. How can I be acting weird?”

“I don’t know”, Kacchan said, this time a bit frustrated. “But there’s something off about you, I just don’t know what it is”.

“I – maybe it’s because I ate something weird at breakfast this morning –“

“You suck at lying, too”.

“*Fine*. But I don’t know why you think I’m being weird”.

“Whatever, nerd”.

“Now you’re the one being weird”.

“Shut up”.

A pause, comfortable.

“So”, Kacchan broke the silence. “What’ve you got for me today?”

“Oh. Well, uh. I, um, I wanted to talk a bit about how I feel. Felt. Um”.

“So that’s why you’re being weird, then”.

“No! There’s nothing to be weird about!”, Izuku tried to defend himself. “I just think it’s important that you know how everything that happened affected me so we can understand how it affected you and try to find a way to –“

“Deku”.

“Y-Yes?”

“I’m messing with you again”, a scoff. “Learn to read the room”.

“O-Oh. Right. Ok”.

Awkward silence.

“Whenever you’re ready, nerd”.

“O-Ok”, Izuku said, head lowered. He looked uncertain, but determined.

He took a deep breath in, letting it out through his mouth slowly. Kacchan watched with impatience.

“Look –“

A knock on the door.

“Hello, Bakugou-kun”, a nurse’s head popped into the room. “Recovery Girl is here to see you. Can she come in?”

Kacchan exchanged one glance with Izuku, trying to read him. Before he could provide the nurse with an answer, the door was pushed open and the small figure of Recovery Girl stepped inside – despite Kacchan’s lack of confirmation.

“Midoriya-kun”, she greeted, seeming slightly surprised. “Fancy seeing you here”.

“Recovery Girl!”, Izuku greeted. “H-Hi. Nice to see you”.

“I can tell you the same, my boy. As for you”, she pointed her cane at Kacchan, stepping closer to him. “How have you been behaving?”

“I didn’t do anything”, Kacchan provided grumpily, which didn’t earn him any points.

“Good. You shouldn’t be doing anything”, Recovery Girl said.

The nurse who had announced her was following her closely, and then she placed a step beside the bed so that Recovery Girl could hop on. She did, inspecting Kacchan’s casted

arms.

“You made a number on this one”, she commented after a while, gesturing at Kacchan’s rebroken hand. “The other one can be cleared today, but this one will need to stay in the cast”.

“For how long?”, Kacchan asked, sounding angrily disappointed.

“Long enough for it to heal on its own”, Recovery Girl told him sharply. “Aizawa told me that you did it on purpose, so take this as a lesson to be learned”.

“I didn’t do it on purpose, I was trying to check if my quirk was still here!”, Kacchan protested, angry.

“Why wouldn’t it still be here?”, Recovery Girl asked, suspicious.

Kacchan’s lips formed a thin, displeased line. He hesitated for a second too long.

“I wanted to check if I could still use it”, he corrected himself. “That’s what I meant”.

“I see”, Recovery Girl said, removing the cast from Kacchan’s good arm, “but there were better ways of doing that. You were reckless, so your arm stays in this cast until your hand is doing better. It needs more time to heal”.

“Come *on* –“

“I’ll see what I can do in a couple of weeks”.

“A couple of *weeks*?!”

“Yes, and that’s the best you’re going to get. Now sit still, will you”, she announced right before leaning in and giving him a peck on the cheek.

Kacchan made a disgusted face, but didn’t lean away from Recovery Girl. Her quirk soon enough made an effect, because Kacchan flexed and unflexed his now good hand with ease.

She hopped off the little step with ease and nodded at the nurse, who stepped in to check on the free arm. Once they assessed Kacchan was as well as he could be, Recovery Girl placed both hands on the top of her cane.

“Keep behaving, trouble boy”, she advised, turning to look at Izuku. “And you, keep an eye on him”.

“H-Hai”, Izuku nodded. He had stepped away from the bed in order to give the healing hero space to work, but now he was back at Kacchan’s side, anxiously avoiding to look at him.

“You’re seeming more aware today, Bakugou”, she commented. “Maybe you’ll be out of here before your arm is out of that cast”.

“I’ll hold you on that”, Kacchan responded grumpily.

“And since you’ve been acting properly to my staff, I have good news for you”, she continued. “I’m allowing you to get your phone back”.

“*Finally*”, Kacchan groaned. He kept flexing his good hand, as if to make sure it would stay functional.

“But – if you overwork yourself, I’m taking it back right away, do you understand?”

“Yes”, Kacchan rolled his eyes.

“Yes…?”

“Yes, ma’am”, he added, sounding like the words tasted bitter on his tongue.

“Good”, she nodded. “Your mom will bring it to you later today. I already talked to her. You can use it to study and to distract yourself while you’re still here”.

“Ok”.

“Call me if you need anything. I’ll leave you two alone, now”, she announced, heading towards the door.

Izuku looked at Kacchan, waiting for him to thank the old lady for her service, but instead he used his now free hand to sign: *old hag* with a shit-eating grin stamped on his face.

Izuku offered him a disapproving look before shouting after her:

“T-Thank you, Recovery Girl!”

The old lady merely waved her hand and walked out the door, the nurse closing it behind them.

“Well”, Kacchan was the one who broke the silence. “At least I’ve got one arm back. I was so *done* having people do everything for me”.

Izuku turned to him again, his eyes becoming softer.

“You were having a hard time accepting that, weren’t you?”, he asked sympathetically.

“Tell me about it”, Kacchan rolled his eyes. “I couldn’t even grab some water without feeling like a helpless baby”.

“You were severely injured, Kacchan. It’s only natural –“

“Ah, spare me”, he interrupted. “I don’t need your little motivational speech”.

A pause. It stretched on.

“I was terrified, you know”.

“Hm?”

“When I found you. I was terrified”.

Silence.

“Well, actually, as soon as I heard you were still inside the building, I got terrified. But when I found you – I don’t think I can even describe the feeling”.

Kacchan stared at him.

“I think I understood you a little bit better, back then. Why you were so upset –“, he hesitated, swallowing dry. “Why you were so… *shaken* by watching me die. I could barely go through watching *you* die. And I don’t want to repeat that ever again. I can’t imagine what it would be like, going through that twice like you did”.

Silence.

“So yeah, I understand why you called me quirkless. Even though I don’t agree with what you did”.

“I already told you –“

“You’re sorry, I know. And I’m sorry too”.

A pause.

“That’s why I wanted to talk about feelings today”.

“Yeah, I’m waiting on that”.

“I think I get your point, now. During all those arguments, all those discussions. You were just trying to preserve yourself”.

“Preserve *my*self?”

“Sure, you were trying to protect me too, but mostly – you were trying to protect yourself. From feeling the pain of… watching something like that again”.

Silence.

“Am I wrong?”

Kacchan thought for a moment.

“No”, he ended up admitting. “But I wasn’t thinking about myself back then. I was just thinking about you, and keeping you safe”.

Izuku looked away. He wasn’t used to all this honesty coming from the usually emotionally-constipated Kacchan, which meant this conversation was quickly becoming something he didn’t know how to handle.

“So you do care”.

“How many times am I going to have to say it?”

Silence.

“You don’t believe me”, Kacchan accused, and if Izuku didn’t know him better he would have dared to say he sounded almost sad.

“I do! I do, now”, he tried to defend himself.

“You sure don’t sound like it, Deku”.

“I do believe you! it’s just – It’s hard, for me”.

“What is?”

“Having to go through that all over again, inside my head. Having to go through…”

“Through what?”

Izuku bit his lower lip.

“Kacchan, there’s something I need to tell you”.

“Well, go the hell ahead”.

Izuku lowered his eyes.

“I – I was connected to the villain”.

“What villain?”

“The one in the sewer. I was bound to him, just like I was bound to you for a month. I could feel what he felt”.

It took a while for Kacchan’s eyes to become wide.

“I know it wasn’t your fault”, Izuku added before he could say anything. “And I don’t blame you, not in the slightest. I just think you should know”.

Silence. Tenser, this time.

“How long?”

“What?”

“How long were you bound to him? For how long did you… feel everything?”

Izuku met Kacchan’s eyes.

“I don’t know”, he admitted. “I honestly don’t. Minutes felt like hours, or maybe it was the other way around. But I really don’t know”.

Silence. Kacchan was staring straight ahead, good hand tightened into a fist and jaw locked into a serious expression.

Izuku waited by his side, quiet. He didn't know what else to say – he didn't know what Kacchan was thinking or feeling.

Eventually, Kacchan broke the silence:

"I think I need some rest, now".

And Izuku took that as his cue to leave. He knew Kacchan wasn't tired – at least he didn't look like it –, but most of all he knew Kacchan would never admit to needing to rest, even if he really needed it. What Kacchan was telling him is that he needed time to think, on his own, about what Izuku was telling him, and Izuku respected his friend too much not to attend to his veiled request. He stepped away and bowed his head.

"I'll see you tomorrow, Kacchan".

"Ok".

Izuku spared him one final sad look before he turned around and left.

From: Kacchan

I'm sorry.

From: Deku

You don't have to apologize.

From: Kacchan

Yes I do.

From: Kacchan

I didn't think about you when I did what I did. I didn't think that you would be bound to that guy. The thought never even crossed my mind until you told me about it

From: Deku

Kacchan. I know

From: Deku

You have nothing to be sorry for, ok? you did what you had to do

From: Deku

I understand

From: Kacchan

I'm going to make it up to you

From: Deku

You really don't have to. Please don't do anything

From: Kacchan

Deku, I can't even begin to imagine the pain you must have gone through

From: Deku

I know

From: Deku

But I understand

From: Kacchan

I want to make it up to you

From: Deku

Then recover and get your other arm healed. Deal?

From: Kacchan

No deal

From: Deku

Come on Kacchan

From: Kacchan

It really disturbed me.

From: Kacchan

Knowing that you went through that, and that I didn't even know

From: Kacchan

I was just sitting there the whole time, waiting on news. While you were in there suffering because of what I did.

From: Deku

If I had known this would upset you so much I wouldn't have said anything

From: Kacchan

You would keep this from me?

From: Deku

I just don't want you to think you owe me something because you don't

From: Deku

If anything, I'm the one who owes you

From: Deku

You saved my life

From: Kacchan

And from what I'm told you saved mine

From: Kacchan

You still haven't talked about that bit much

From: Deku

I will

From: Deku

We can talk about it when I visit tomorrow

From: Kacchan

I'll charge you on that

From: Deku

So how do you feel having one free arm?

From: Kacchan

Don’t change the subject.

From: Deku

Oh, come on. Don’t act like you’re not glad

From: Kacchan

I am, kinda

From: Kacchan

I feel a bit more like a human person now, instead of a blob of broken limbs

From: Kacchan

I could still use my other hand, though

From: Deku

You shouldn’t have broken it.

From: Kacchan

You shouldn’t tell me what to do, how about that

From: Deku

I mean it, Kacchan. There were other ways we could have tested the theory

From: Kacchan

What about my quirk?

From: Deku

We shouldn’t talk about this over text

From: Kacchan

Did you test it?

From: Deku

Not yet

From: Kacchan

Why the hell not

From: Deku

I want us to do it together

From: Kacchan

Bullshit

From: Kacchan

I'll be in the hospital for weeks. Aren't you the tiniest bit curious?

From: Deku

I am, but I'm not doing this alone

From: Deku

Just like you shouldn't have just gone and broken your own hand, on your own

From: Kacchan

You're really not letting this go are ya

From: Deku

No. I get worried about you, you know

From: Kacchan

Welcome to my life

From: Kacchan

Now you know what it's like to constantly worry about an idiot who breaks his bones on purpose

From: Deku

Did you

From: Deku

Did you just call yourself an idiot

From: Kacchan

No I didn't shut the fuck up

From: Kacchan

If anything you're the idiot here

From: Kacchan

Now go to sleep before I break your bones

From: Deku

All right Kacchan

From: Deku

I'll see you tomorrow ^_^

"So, are you ever going to tell me how you got your quirk back?"

Izuku blushed and immediately tried to hide it.

"Are you sure you don't remember?"

"Nope".

"Not even a tiny bit?"

"I already told you I fucking don't".

A pause.

"I'm – I'm sure it will come back to you".

"Just tell me about it already".

A sigh.

"Let's make a deal".

"No deals".

“If you agree to what I had in mind for today, I’ll tell you how it went”.

“Why are you being so mysterious about it?”

“I’m not being mysterious!”

“Yes, you are. You got all red and blushing and shit, and now you’re trying to change the subject. What’d I do, rub my blood all over you? Because if that’s what happened that’s gross, but it’s already in the past”.

Izuku closed his eyes for a moment, trying to recompose himself.

“You didn’t rub your blood on me”.

“Then what did I do?”

“I’ll tell you about it if you tell me something”.

Kacchan thought for a bit.

“No”.

“You don’t even know what it is!”

“I’m not bargaining with you. You either tell me or piss off”.

A sigh. Kacchan was starting to sound more like himself, but there was still something off about his behavior in the overall picture.

Which was why Izuku couldn’t tell him about the kiss. Not yet, at least.

“You don’t want me to tell you”.

“Newsflash, asshole: you don’t know what I want”.

“Yes, but what I know is that it will come back to you –“

“Deku –“

“Kacchan –“

“If you’re not gonna tell me, then –“

“Then what? Leave?”

“Well, yeah!”

“Fine!”

“*Fine*”.

Izuku marched away. He stopped in front of the closed door, silent.

“I’ll take a break before we start arguing”.

“Suit yourself”.

“In the meantime, please try to understand that there must be a reason why I don’t want to talk about it. I’m sure you didn’t want to talk about a lot of things when you first woke up in the hospital”.

Instead of waiting for Kacchan’s response, Izuku stepped away from the room.

“So”.

“So”.

“Are you ready to talk now?”

“Whatever”.

A raised eyebrow.

“Fine. It’s not like I can get up and run away from this conversation”.

“As if you’d ever run away from anything”.

“Hah. That’s right”.

“But what do you mean you can’t get up?”

Kacchan looked aside, seeming angrily embarrassed.

“Every time I try I end up getting super dizzy”.

“Kacchan”, a horrified whisper. “Why didn’t you tell me that?”

“It’s not like I get to do any talking with your constant notebook-rambling”, a scoff.

Izuku’s shoulders became stiff and he looked away, embarrassed. Kacchan rolled his eyes.

“I’m just *messing* with you, for fuck’s sake”.

“I can never tell!”

“I know!”

“Then why do you keep doing it?”

“It’s not like I do it on purpose, nerd, it just – comes off like that”.

“Well, I think we need to talk about it”.

“*Really* –“

“I think we need to establish some boundaries”.

Silence.

“About this or…?”

“About several things, yeah”, Izuku said, crossing his arms above his chest.

“Fine”, Kacchan agreed, realizing the conversation tone was becoming more serious.

“First. No calling me quirkless”.

“Which you aren’t anymore”.

“I know, but in any circumstances. I want this to be our forbidden word”.

“Forbidden word?”

“Yeah, as in, I don’t call you weak, you don’t call me quirkless. Ever”.

“I ain’t weak”.

“Exactly”.

“So you’ve got no fucking reason to call me that”.

“*Exactly*”.

“But you used to be. You know, the Q-word”.

“I know. And that will always be a part of me. And I’m not ashamed of that, Kacchan, I need you to understand that. I was born this way, and there’s nothing wrong with this. The reason I don’t want you to call me quirkless is because it reminds me of a dark period of my life – *the* darkest period of my life. It’s not the word itself, it’s what it represents, it’s the memories it brings back. Do you understand?”

A pleading look. Kacchan looked away.

“Yeah”.

“Good. Second point: we’re friends now”.

“Ok”.

“That’s not just something I’m saying. It’s something that we both agree on, right? Because it’s ok if you don’t want to be friends-friends, it’s ok if you want to settle with colleagues or acquaintances or –“

“Deku”.

“W-What?”

“We’re friends. Colleagues and acquaintances don’t almost die for each other, especially more than once”.

“Oh”.

“Yeah”.

“Ok. So, um, as friends, we can banter and all that. It’s all ok, as long as you don’t call me the Q-word”.

“Ok”.

“And – I don’t know. Maybe we can hang out more”.

“This is way cheesier than you pictured in your head, you know”.

“I – I-I –“

“Deku”.

“*Yes*”.

“You don’t have to control it”.

“What?”

“Friendship, dickhead. You don’t control it. You just go through it. Stop trying to take control, because I really can’t stand being ordered around”.

“Oh, right, ok –“

“We’re friends now and that’s it. We don’t need a hanging out schedule”.

“Right”, Izuku said, opening his notebook and erasing something with the eraser on the top of his pencil. “So, ok, we’re friends”.

“Yeah. Are you gonna make a shirt that says it?”

Izuku thought about it.

“N-No?”

“You don’t sound so sure there”.

“No, I won’t make a shirt”, he said more confidently, now erasing more things from his notebook. “But since we’re friends, why didn’t you tell me about getting dizzy?”

“I don’t know”, Kacchan shrugged. “It’s not something that pops up in regular conversations”.

“But you should have said something! Have you talked to Recovery Girl and Aizawa sensei –“

“*Yes*, and they have all reached the same conclusion that this is something related to my head injury, yadda yadda yadda. Can you stop worrying so much now?”

“Third point – worrying”.

“Jesus”.

“We worry about each other. I think we need to accept that”.

“Is there another option here?”

“No?”

“I know, I was just messing with you. *Again*”.

Izuku groaned.

“You’ll get there eventually, Deku. You did it once before. By the way, why are we playing this boundary game if you have your memories back?”

“Because there’s still things we need to talk about!”

“Yeah, a whole notebook worth of them”.

“The notebook material is almost over, by now”.

Kacchan stared at him.

“What, is your handwriting huge or something? How did you occupy a whole notebook with just the shit we’ve been talking about?”

“I – It’s like you said. I overwrite. It’s just sparse thoughts here and there, and when we talk, I give off the general idea”.

“Hm”.

Silence. Izuku shifted his weight uncomfortably.

“But as I was saying”, he cleared his throat. “I’ll always worry about you. You’ll always worry about me. I think we need to find a way to deal with that in a healthy manner”.

Kacchan scoffed.

“Agreed”, he rolled his eyes.

“So whenever you’re getting worried – you can, I don’t know. Text me. Or call me.”

“Tch. I ain’t doing that”.

“I’m not telling you to do that”, Izuku pointed out. “I’m just saying you can”.

“I ain’t. I’m not some helpless little thing who needs to call you just to make sure you’re ok. I’m not your damn mom”.

“I know you’re not”, Izuku pointed out. “But I think doing that would make you feel better”.

Kacchan sighed.

“You’re not gonna call me several times a day just to make sure I’m ok, will you?”

Izuku blushed again.

“Not *several* times –“

“Deku, come *on*”.

“Look, I remember ok?”

Silence.

“I get that it was hard dealing with me when I woke up with no memories. I *get it*. It must have sucked to you. Now that everything is in my head again, I can only imagine how terrible it felt. But now I can also remember everything that happened – and Kacchan, I’m sorry for this, but you’re very emotionally constipated”.

“What the *fuck* are you talking about?”

“You were touch-starved for *years*! And you never dared to ask anyone for a hug until my literal soul was stuck with you!”

“Now listen here you bastard –“

“I’m not trying to shove things on your face, or to make you feel bad, or, or to mock you”, Izuku added quickly. “I’m just saying you can count on me. Whatever you need, you can ask me. Always”.

Kacchan glared at him, angry. He looked healthier for an instant, as if more life had found its way to his face. As if he could stand up and go on about his day.

“I’m not that type of person”, he said simply, through gritted teeth.

“Well, I’m not the kind of person who sits idly around and does nothing while a friend is suffering”, Izuku retorted, equally angry. It was as if his rage was mimicking Kacchan’s. “I’m not telling you to call me and rant about your life, because I know you wouldn’t do that. I’m just telling you you can trust me”.

Silence. Kacchan glared at his own bed, grumpy.

“Look”, Izuku continued after a few moments. “We both saw each other die. We’re past this kind of stuff, ok? We’re past a *lot* of stuff by now. So just trust me like I trust you?”

Kacchan looked at Izuku, still glaring.

“Would it be so hard? Do we need to have a whole argument over how you can *trust* me again?”

Kacchan kept glaring at him.

Then, the corners of his eyes became the slightest bit softer.

“I trust you”.

“Thank you”, a sincere remark.

“I just don’t know how to do this sort of thing you want me to do”.

“What thing?”

“Calling you, keeping in touch. I’m not that guy. And I don’t want you to go around creating expectations for me to fulfill again, otherwise we’ll end up at the same spot from last time”.

“You mean arguing our lungs away during a villain invasion?”

“Yeah, exactly”.

Izuku’s shoulders sagged as he sighed.

“I understand”.

“I can’t be who you want me to be, Deku”, Kacchan added, serious. “All I can be is me. And I’m angry, and grumpy, and short-tempered. I go feral over the tiniest shit you can imagine. And this is who I am”.

Izuku studied his face for a while, empathy written all over his eyes. Then, in a surge of adrenaline, he reached forward and grabbed Kacchan’s hand.

Kacchan didn’t pull it away.

“I know, Kacchan”, Izuku said lovingly. “I don’t want you to change”.

“Are you *sure*? Because you keep making demands –“

“I’m not making demands”, Izuku interrupted him. “I’m just…”

A sigh.

“You’re right. I might be a bit of a control freak”.

“Newsflash”.

“Oh, stop it”.

A pause.

“But really. Sorry for trying to tell you what to do. I just wanted you to know that – you can count on me”.

“I know that. Even when I was trying to get rid of you, you wouldn’t get the hell out of my case. I *know* I can count on you”.

“But I mean for *anything*”.

“I know that”.

“Good. T-That’s… good”.

A knock echoed on the door.

“Hello”, a nurse greeted, popping her head into the room and smiling softly at Izuku. “Time for his meds”, she gestured, opening the door all the way.

“Guess this is my cue to leave”, Izuku sighed, grabbing his notebook. “Same time tomorrow?”

“I ain’t going anywhere”, Kacchan scoffed.

“See you, Kacchan. Be nice to the staff”.

“Don’t tell me what to do”.

“Ok”.

“Ok”.

From: Kacchan

I'm curious about something

From: Deku

What is it?

From: Kacchan

The shirt I gave you as a birthday present. Did you like it?

Deku is typing…

Deku is typing…

From: Deku

I loved it

From: Deku

It instantly became one of my favorites

From: Kacchan

One of

From: Kacchan

The audacity

From: Deku

It was on my top five shirts

From: Deku

The other four were gifts from All Might Kacchan, you can't compete with that

From: Kacchan

The hell I can't

From: Kacchan

If I want to surpass him as number one hero I should be able to do something as simple as giving you your favorite shirt

From: Deku

That turned out sweeter than you had intended, isn't it?

From: Kacchan

Shut up

From: Deku

You can still give me my favorite shirt

From: Deku

The one you gave me got ruined, back at the wreckage

From: Kacchan

I didn't know that

From: Deku

I didn't tell you

From: Deku

But now I'm giving you the chance to become competitive over a shirt

From: Kacchan

I'll beat All Might's ass

From: Deku

Don't say stuff like that!

From: Kacchan

Don't tell me what to say

From: Deku

Oh, yeah, right. Sorry

From: Kacchan

It's a figure of speech Deku

From: Kacchan

Really, I don't know how you do it

From: Deku

I'm sorryyyy

From: Deku

I'll work on it

From: Kacchan

You're a lost cause

Izuku woke up in the middle of the night, his heart hammering inside his chest.

He had just been asleep, but now it felt like he had run a marathon. He gasped for air and tried to make sense of what was happening to him, until he realized there was nothing wrong – he was merely lying in bed, at his home.

He allowed his head to fall against his pillow and sighed deeply, startled. It had probably been a nightmare – he had been having his fair share of those –, one of those he forgot about as soon as he woke up. He tried doing some breathing exercises he had been taught at school, but none of that seemed to work. If anything, the fear – because he was feeling it, now that he thought about it – was only becoming more intense by the second.

And then – it stopped.

It happened out of nowhere. One minute, Izuku was nearly hyperventilating on his bed, and on the next he could breathe again as if nothing had happened. The contrast was so sharp that Izuku's eyes drooped and he fell back asleep, in a matter of seconds, unable to try and think about what had caused such a reaction.

He figured it out the next day.

If anything, he figured out a lot of things the next day.

When he arrived at Recovery Girl's medical bay, there was a commotion right outside Kacchan's room. Aizawa spotted him amidst the nurses gathering there and stepped away to greet him, a tired yet serious look on his face.

"Midoriya", he said simply, authoritatively. "Today is not a good day for you to be here".

"Why? What happened?", Izuku asked, frowning and feeling anxious. He suddenly remembered the weird episode from the previous night – the waking up and falling back asleep. Had it been a sign? Intuition? Sixth sense? Something that told him Kacchan was in trouble?

Aizawa looked like he didn't want to have that conversation, but he led Izuku to the waiting area and made him sit down.

"We figured out what's wrong with Bakugou", he announced simply, much to Izuku's surprise.

"Something's wrong with him?!", he asked, voice high pitched.

Aizawa ran a tired hand across his face.

"First of all, calm down", he ordered. "The last thing I need is another freaking-out student".

Izuku got back to his feet, too nervous to sit still.

"Sensei", he said, trying his best to sound as calm as possible – even if his voice still came off shaky. "What's going on?"

Aizawa sighed, looking exhausted.

"I'll try to summarize it for you".

"Ok", a shaky response.

"Bakugou has been taking anxiety medication", he started. "He had two panic attacks after he was taken in, and he underwent a severely traumatic situation. His body is still recovering, so we couldn't allow him to keep putting it under so much stress. It was a medical necessity".

Izuku swallowed dry. Now a lot of things made sense – how Kacchan seemed to be more agreeable, more comprehensive, and less explosive about everything. Could that have been an effect of the medication? Izuku had assumed it had to do with the pain killers, but now that Aizawa explained it to him it made a lot more sense.

“But as it turns out”, Aizawa continued, “that the lack of stress was also prejudicial to his body”.

Izuku frowned.

“What do you mean?”, he asked, wary.

Aizawa sighed again.

“Bakugou’s quirk is to secrete nitroglycerin. He uses that to ignite his explosions, but his whole body produces it. Prolonged exposure to nitroglycerin lowers the heartrate, and it may also cause several unpleasant side effects”.

Izuku’s mouth hung open. Kacchan’s quirk was harming him?!

“The thing is – before all this, when he was healthy, Bakugou was always stressed out. It’s part of his explosive personality”.

“*H-Hai*”.

“His stress usually made up for any heartrate decrease the nitroglycerin in his sweat caused. But once we introduced the anxiety medication, that lowered his heartbeat as well. He’s been feeling weak and dizzy whenever he tries to stand up, but no one linked those dots to nitroglycerin poisoning because we had assumed the high levels were just a part of his quirk”.

“Wait”, Izuku said, baffled. “So you’re saying –“

“That being stressed out is what keeps Bakugou alive? Yes, I was also surprised, trouble kid”.

Izuku stared at his teacher in disbelief.

“I only figured it out after the fifth blood test came back with the same results”, Aizawa continued. “I shouldn’t have taken so long”.

“And how is he now?”, Izuku asked, worried.

“Stable. We’re going to use new medication to help with the panic attacks, and mostly rely on therapy to keep him stable. His therapist is in there talking to him as we speak, and I don’t think it’s a good idea to let you in there today”.

“But I don’t understand”, Izuku protested. “I’ve been talking to him for several days, now. He mentioned feeling dizzy, but he seemed ok to me. You told me he would be debilitated, but it never felt that way”.

Aizawa spared him a long, thoughtful look, as if he was trying to decide whether or not he should speak his mind.

“That’s how I figured it out”, he ended up saying eventually.

“What?”

“Whenever he spoke to you, he got better. It was a noticeable change. But as soon as you left, or minutes before you arrived, he would always be debilitated, weak. At first, I thought it was some sort of teenage heartsickness, but then I remembered you are the one person who always manages to rile him up, no matter what”.

Izuku blushed.

“Ever since you both became my students, and probably even before that, no one manages to stress Bakugou out as you do”, Aizawa continued. “So I started to realize you were still doing that, and that was what was making him better. His heartrate would spike up and back into normal levels whenever you were with him, because he would be stressed by your presence. It took me a while to realize *why* you were making him better, and what was actually going on with his body”.

Izuku opened and closed his mouth, at a loss for words.

“But – But I – I tried my best not to do anything stressful! I avoided certain topics, I didn’t get into arguments – I tried so hard to – to not make him – I –“

He felt heartbroken. So that was it, then? No matter what he did or how hard he tried, Kacchan was always bound to be stressed out by his mere existence? How could they be friends, if all Izuku did was rile Kacchan up? How could they be close, if Izuku’s presence made Kacchan’s heart race and his muscles tense? How could they even speak to each other without Izuku fearing he would be harming Kacchan without knowing?

What was it about him that Kacchan felt so revolted by? Neither of them wanted Kacchan to change, but did that mean Izuku would be the one who needed to? What was he doing wrong, what was *wrong* with him that made Kacchan feel so stressed out?

Izuku couldn’t say he wasn’t stressed out when he talked to Kacchan as well, so maybe he wasn’t the problem. Maybe their friendship was the problem? But then again, the reasons why Izuku felt stressed out weren’t the same as Kacchan’s. He felt stressed because he had almost lost him, and he had watched him die, and now he was trying to build a friendship with a guy he had known all his life, but couldn’t seem to get right.

Except Kacchan had also watched him die, and Kacchan had also almost lost him, and that had happened twice. And he trusted Kacchan enough now to believe him when he said the whole experience had been awful, and that he didn’t want to lose Izuku. So if they were experiencing the same fear…

Wait.

It couldn't be, could it?

It couldn't. It was impossible. This was just his mind playing tricks on him.

But what if there was a reason why Kacchan's heart raced when he was with Izuku? What if there was a reason why Kacchan's blood pressure seemed to spike whenever they spoke, even if it was to discuss the faintest of subjects?

"I – I need to see him –"

"*No*. That's final".

"But *sensei* –"

"Midoriya, I know you're worried about him. But rest assured he is being taken care of by excellent medical professionals, he won't need for anything as long as I'm here. Go back to the dorm and rest; you can talk to him tomorrow".

Tomorrow. Tomorrow! Tomorrow was such a long time for his heart, aching desperately for answers. He would be stuck counting each minute and each second of each passing hour, until tomorrow arrived and he was able to see Kacchan. And the things that heart was feeling! Fear, and anger, and confusion, and so much *longing,* all bundled together with no boundaries, no limits. He was feeling everything at once, almost like back when he was a ghost, sharing his feelings with Kacchan.

Exactly like his time as a ghost.

That explained the episode from last night. Why he had woken up with a fear that wasn't his own, strong enough to make him dizzy. He sat down on the waiting chair again, hands shaking.

"Sensei –"

"Midoriya, I already told you –"

"But I really need to see him, it's so important –"

"Go. Back to the dorm. I won't say it again".

"But *sensei* –"

Aizawa spared him a nearly deadly look. Izuku shrunk on his seat at the intensity of his teacher's gaze.

"Not that I need to justify myself to you", Aizawa added, harsh. "But like I said, he's with his therapist right now. She's explaining the medication to him, along with everything else that's been happening to his body. You can't go in right now, not while he's adjusting. So go to your room and stay there".

Izuku's lips formed a thin displeased line. He understood where his teacher was coming from, no matter how desperate he was to see Kacchan and test both his theories. Plus, he was already in trouble from barging into the fallen building – he didn't need any more negative points on his side.

"Do you understand what I'm saying?", Aizawa demanded at his silence, raising an eyebrow at him.

Izuku lowered his head, nodding solemnly.

"Good. I have to go back and talk to the medical staff, so I don't want to see you lingering here", he warned one last time. "Come back tomorrow".

Izuku nodded again, watching as his teacher turned around and approached the medical staff. Recovery Girl was there, talking to some nurses, and she greeted Aizawa as he stepped close to her.

The door to Kacchan's room was closed, so Izuku couldn't see anything. He could only try to imagine what was going on inside – Doctor Matsuo talking to him calmly, explaining the situation to him; Kacchan being angry that he was being medicated for anxiety; Kacchan trying his best to keep a strong façade despite the fear he was feeling. Because Izuku was feeling fear too, but how could he know if that was his or if that was Kacchan's?

He had never considered the possibility that they were back to sharing their emotions, but that surely explained a lot. Why they kept arguing, for one – they were both nervous. Why he had felt so calm and easy while talking about the notebook with Kacchan, even if just the thought of it made him freak out – it was Kacchan's response to the anxiety medication being projected onto him.

He walked out of the medbay and back to the dorm with his head full of questions. If they were indeed sharing feelings, would they be shared forever? Just like One For All? He still hadn't tested that. Was this an aftermath of the Soulmonger's quirk or was it an aftermath of the One For All transfer? Did Kacchan realize it too, or was this simply an invention of Izuku's brain?

He couldn't be sure of anything anymore. He ignored his friends at the common room and went straight to his bedroom, closing the door behind himself and heading straight to his bed.

He fished his phone from his pocket and stared at the screen. It would take at least 12 hours until he was able to see Kacchan again. But there was still some way he could reach him.

From: Deku

How are you?

From: Deku

I stopped by, but they didn't let me in

From: Deku

Just send me some news when you can, ok? I'm worried.

Sharing his feelings with Kacchan again was something that wasn't in his plans, and that he would have to think about a lot. When did it start? He was fairly sure it had been after the One For All transfer, but he hadn't noticed it until he woke up in fear the night before. Maybe now it only worked if the emotion was intense? Because he didn't recall feeling anything odd or out of the ordinary in the time Kacchan spent in the hospital.

Except now that he thought about it there had been some sudden spikes of pain that hit him out of nowhere back while he was at his mom's, but he had dismissed those as just a part of his recovering spleen… In what other occasions had he felt Kacchan's feelings without knowing?

It felt a bit impossible that he was sharing feelings with Kacchan again, and his brain wouldn't stop telling him this was all a figment of his imagination. But deep down, Izuku knew there was something wrong, and the sooner he proved his theory right (or wrong), the sooner he would find a way to fix things.

He ended up dozing off, phone still in his hand, worried thoughts about Kacchan plaguing his mind and his soul.

The answer didn't come until two hours later.

From: Kacchan

What do you know?

Izuku blinked at the screen, trying to understand Kacchan's question.

From: Deku

Aizawa sensei told me the basics. How are you faring up?

From: Kacchan

I'm fine

From: Kacchan

Don't wanna talk about it

From: Deku

Ok

From: Deku

What do you want to talk about?

From: Kacchan

How do you have your quirk back?

From: Deku

I'm not discussing this over text

From: Kacchan

Why not?

From: Deku

It's dangerous

From: Kacchan

To whom?

From: Deku

You know, Kacchan

From: Deku

Let's talk about something else

From: Deku

Have you been talking to your friends? How are they?

From: Kacchan

You know what? I'm going to sleep

From: Deku

Ok

From: Deku

Are you really ok?

From: Kacchan

Yes Deku

From: Kacchan

Stop motherhenning me

From: Deku

All right

Izuku set his phone aside and stared at the ceiling, trying to think of what he should do. He was feeling tired, and mostly overwhelmed, but he still wasn't sure if that was coming from him or from Kacchan. He would have to find out on the following day.

"Hi".

"Hi".

"So how are you?"

"Same I told you yesterday", Kacchan said. "I'm fine".

His face was impassive, revealing nothing to Izuku's searching eyes. He sighed, discontent.

"I thought we had agreed we'd be more honest with each other".

“We never agreed on that”.

“I was hoping we could”.

Silence.

“I know you must be upset”, Izuku continued. “But now that everyone knows what’s wrong –“

“I told you I don’t want to talk about it”.

Izuku lowered his head.

“I think we *should* talk about it”.

“Deku…”

“Don’t you trust me?”

Kacchan stared at him. He looked very displeased, but eventually he clicked his tongue and nodded.

“I do”.

“Then be honest with me”.

“I could tell you the same”.

A sigh.

“Kacchan…”

“Tell me how you got your quirk back”.

“I don’t *want* to”.

A pause.

“Why not?”

Honesty, honesty, honesty. How could Izuku demand it if he didn’t give it back? He decided to speak the truth, even if that cost him his peace of mind.

“I’m afraid to”, Izuku admitted, hands starting to shake. He wasn’t looking at Kacchan, but rather at his own feet.

“What? Afraid?”, Kacchan asked, confused. “Why?”

Izuku stepped away from the bed, hands fiddling with the hem of his shirt. He hadn’t brought his notebook with him today.

“I’m afraid you’re going to hate me if I tell you”, he said, sincere.

Because he was afraid. He was terrified of what would happen to their relationship if Kacchan learned – or remembered – about the kiss, which hadn’t really been a kiss but still counted as one. They had come such a long way just trying to become friends; Izuku wasn’t ready to risk everything by telling something so embarrassing to Kacchan.

He also wasn’t ready to keep this to himself. Kaminari was the only person who knew about it, and he had promised Izuku not to tell anyone. But Izuku knew – especially now that he was hypothetically sharing his feelings with Kacchan again – that the boy wouldn’t be able to keep this a secret from Kacchan much longer, and Izuku would rather Kacchan learned about the kiss from him than from anybody else.

Silence. He could feel Kacchan’s intense gaze glued on him, but couldn’t bring himself to look.

The awkward pause stretched on, but Izuku couldn’t meet his eyes. He felt raw, and exposed, and naked. He felt afraid, and cold. He wondered if Kacchan could feel that too.

“I think we’re back to sharing feelings”, Izuku asked, because he really needed to know if the remaining empathic bond was real or if it was just his mind starting to go crazy and playing tricks on him.

But after a few moments of silence, Kacchan responded:

“Yeah”.

Izuku finally brought himself to look at the boy.

Kacchan was staring at him seriously, but there was a hint of comprehension in his crimson eyes.

“For how long?”, Izuku asked, nervous. Kacchan shrugged.

“I don’t know”, he admitted. “I just realized it now”.

“I realized it two nights ago”, Izuku admitted. “I woke up feeling so much *fear*”.

It could have been his imagination, but Izuku was almost sure Kacchan blushed.

“Don’t know what you’re talking about”, he said dismissively, which Izuku had already expected. Kacchan hated admitting to his fear.

A pause.

“Do you want to tell me what happened?”

Kacchan sighed.

“Will you stay upset if I don’t?”

“I’m not upset”.

“No use lying to someone who can literally feel your emotions, dipshit”.

Izuku lowered his head.

“I’m not upset”, he admitted. “I just wish you were more honest with me. I know you’re afraid of looking weak or dependent or whatever, but you won’t. In my eyes, you will always be the very definition of victory, and nothing can ever change that”.

Kacchan stared at him, pensive. Like he was trying to decide if Izuku’s little speech was enough to make him be more honest.

“I had a dream”, he said, tasting the words on his tongue, “and I didn’t know what it meant”.

“Was that what scared you?”

Kacchan looked like he would rather swallow lava than to reply to that question, but he nodded.

“I wouldn’t say *scare* is the right word. It just shocked me”.

“It must have been a pretty strong shock, then, because I could feel it all the way back at the dorm”.

Kacchan snorted.

“I think we can only feel each other’s feelings when the emotion is very strong”, Izuku added. “Maybe it has to do with One For All, but it could be an after effect from the villain’s quirk. We never really understood why my soul ended up with you and not with him, so maybe… Maybe it’s related”.

Kacchan nodded, silent. Still no angry retort or curse word. Izuku was starting to feel very awkward, because he wasn’t so sure it was the medication this time.

Kacchan looked like he wanted to say something, but didn’t know how to. He looked like Izuku’s presence there was making him terribly uncomfortable, but Izuku couldn’t tell what he was doing wrong.

“Do you want to tell me what the dream was about?”, he asked, feeling suddenly bold. Because that dream was the big elephant in the room, wasn’t it?

Kacchan thought for a while.

“No”, he admitted.

“Why not?”

Silence.

“Kacchan?”

“Because I’m afraid to ruin things”.

It was so off-putting, to hear Kacchan admit to be scared of something so easily. Izuku had a feeling this had nothing to do with his medication, but rather about everything else. He couldn’t help but to think back at how much Kacchan had grown the past year, how much he had changed and yet stayed true to his essence.

He couldn’t help but to be proud.

“It’s ok to be afraid”, Izuku told him gently.

“*Don’t* patronize me”.

“I’m not”, Izuku said, taking a seat at the edge of Kacchan’s bed. “I swear I’m not. I’m just trying to let you know that – whatever it is, it’s ok. You’re not going to ruin anything”.

“You can’t know that”.

“I can, because I won’t let it ruin anything”.

Kacchan scoffed.

“You wanted me to be more honest, right?”

“Yes”.

“Then here it goes. I don’t know how to deal with you”.

Izuku studied his face, waiting for him to continue.

“You make me feel things I don’t know how to feel. Empathic bond or not. And you say stuff, and you act a certain way – that used to infuriate me, but now it doesn’t. I don’t know what to expect. I don’t know how to feel. And you keep acting as if I’m supposed to react in a certain way, but I don’t know what that is and I don’t know how to live up to your expectations. Which is ridiculous, considering you’re you and I’m me. I wasn’t supposed to want to live up to anyone else’s expectations, yet here I am”.

Izuku nodded, signaling for him to go on.

“I don’t know what you want from me, Deku”, he admitted.

A pause.

“What do *you* want from me?”, Izuku asked.

“What?”

“What do you want from me?”, Izuku repeated. “Maybe if you figure that out, it will help you understand what I want from you”.

“You’re not making any sense”.

“Try it”, Izuku encouraged. “Maybe it will help”.

Kacchan thought for a bit. He kept giving Izuku a suspicious look, as if he wasn’t sure what outcome he was supposed to give.

“If you can’t tell me how you got your quirk back”, Kacchan started, sounding like he was tasting each word on his tongue. “Why don’t you show me?”

Izuku’s face became red.

But there, in Kacchan’s eyes, he saw something – something indescribable, but something that gave him courage. Something that told him that maybe things would stay the same if he only gathered the courage to do what he was expected – what he needed – to do.

Kacchan was irradiating fear, but he was also irradiating confidence. Izuku decided to use that in his advantage.

“Are you sure you want me to show you?”, Izuku asked, bold, bold, so bold. Kacchan was half-sitting very still on his bed.

“Yes”, he replied simply.

“Does this have to do with the dream?”, Izuku continued, voice barely above a whisper.

Kacchan stayed silent, but nodded.

Izuku blushed.

He had unconsciously leaned forwards a bit, now that he was sitting in front of Kacchan on the bed. His lips were parted in anticipation, and his heart was hammering inside his chest. His face was probably as red as a tomato, but he kept feeding off Kacchan’s confidence, trying to use that feeling to ground him.

Except Kacchan looked very hesitant, so maybe the confidence was Izuku’s, after all.

They were face to face now, but Izuku’s green eyes were glued to Kacchan’s equally parted lips. They were so close to each other Izuku could feel Kacchan’s breaths coming out as harsh puffs.

They were closer than any friend should be. They had already crossed a boundary – there was no going back from this now – but Izuku was still afraid. Kacchan looked too hesitant.

“Is this ok?”, Izuku asked, voice barely above a whisper. Kacchan nodded softly, causing his nose to brush against Izuku’s.

Izuku brushed his nose against Kacchan’s again, closing his eyes and relishing on that proximity. For a moment, the whole world was resumed to them – noses brushing gently

against each other, breaths coming out quickly and heavily. There was innocence in the gesture.

Then Kacchan suddenly closed the distance between their lips, and they were finally kissing.

Izuku's heart was beating very fast inside his chest – so fast it felt like it was about to burst away from his ribs and fly off into the sunset. And as the tip of Kacchan's tongue began to explore his lower lip, Izuku knew: he could die just then, and he would die happy for a change.

He opened his mouth and allowed Kacchan in, welcoming him with his own tongue. The kiss was messy, and warm, and wet – everything to be expected from two amateurs such as they were – but it was everything Izuku could have wished for and more. His whole body was tingling with the sheer static of their touch, and a shiver ran down his spine as Kacchan's free hand grabbed his waist and pulled him closer.

Kacchan's scent was sweet and intoxicating. It quickly became Izuku's favorite smell in the whole world, and he allowed himself to give into his warmness as he sunk closer to Kacchan.

They broke away, blushing and breathing heavily. Kacchan's pupils were blown wide open, his face flushed a deep red and his lips moist and pink. Izuku was pretty sure he was offering a similar look, but his brain was short-circuiting. He didn't know what to do or say, so he simply sat there, close to Kacchan, looking dumbfounded.

Kacchan sat in equal silence, his good hand still clinging to the front of Izuku's shirt. As if realizing what he was doing, he let go, hand falling next to Izuku's.

Izuku hesitated, and then he gently placed his own hand atop Kacchan's.

"Now what?", Kacchan was the first to ask.

Izuku looked away.

"I just want you to be happy, Kacchan", he said, hesitant. "However that might be".

"Oi, nerd. Look at me".

Izuku raised his eyes. Kacchan was still blushing slightly, but he had a focused look on his face.

Still, he hesitated.

“I’m gonna to say some stuff”, he said eventually, “And you’re gonna reply with true or false. Deal?”

“You’re copying me”, Izuku chuckled, nervous.

“Shut it. I care about you”.

Izuku blushed, looking away.

“True”.

“I want to make you happy, too. It’s only right, after everything I put you through”.

Izuku stared at him, lost. Kacchan raised his eyebrows.

“T-True…?”, Izuku tried hesitantly.

“You’re important to me”, Kacchan said.

“T-True”.

“And I don’t know what love is”.

Izuku frowned.

“But you taught me that”.

Tears found Izuku’s eyes.

“So even if I’m ‘emotionally constipated’, I know this: we have a long way ahead of us, we still have a lot of shit to figure out, but I want to try it out. I want to listen to Doctor Matsuo and try my best to live a happy life. Whether that’s a life with meds or with you, I don’t care”.

Izuku sniffed and Kacchan wiped his tears away with his thumb.

“Oi, Deku, stop crying”, he said, half-authoritative, half-gentle. “You know I hate it when you cry”.

“S-Sorry”.

“Don’t apologize”.

“You really want this? You really want… me?”

Kacchan gazed upon him.

“You’re my constant”, he admitted. “You’ve always been there, and I want to keep it that way. So what have you got to say?”

“True”, Izuku sniffed, smiling wide. “It’s all true”.

Kacchan enveloped him in another kiss, and Izuku had never been happier.

Chapter End Notes

Is there a way to end this thing without being cheesy?

So much of this story was focused in Bakugou's POV I wanted to go back to Midoriya's POV! I also feel like I've already explored enough of Bakugou's personality, so I wanted to leave his decisions and his actions up to you guys' imagination! How do you think the talk with dr. Matsuo went?

I just wanted to say my final thank you to you guys. Without your encouraging comments, your kudos and your support this story was never going to turn out like it did! I know the ending is a bit disappointing, but I did the best I could given the circumstances. I'm still feeling pretty anxious overall, so I worked with what I had. Sorry if the ending didn't meet your expectations! If it's any consolation, I'm planning on a sequel for this story, so subscribe to my profile if you want to read it! I don't know when it's coming out, but soon, I hope ^_^

I can't believe it's been almost two whole years since I first began to write this... I'm definitely going to miss it.

Chapter 28: Love in Seven Words

Chapter Notes

> Yes, you are reading this right. This story just gained an extra chapter!
> This is the first piece of a two-part celebratory writing I decided to do in honor of this story having reached 10 thousand kudos. I hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Katsuki woke up groggily, and as he blinked his eyes open, trying to make sense of his surroundings, he found the tiny little figure of Recovery Girl standing beside his bed and fiddling with his IV. He must have groaned or made some sort of sound as he spotted her, because she craned her head to look at him with her wrinkly expression and offered him a small smile when she saw his eyes opened.

“How did your first night here go?”, she asked, going back to the IV. Katsuki searched his mind for an answer.

“Good, I guess”, he said, feeling slow and sluggish. “I slept the night through”.

“That’s good. You’re recovering well, now”, she nodded simplistically.

Katsuki watched her for a few moments.

“Any chance I’ll get out of here soon?”, he dared to question.

Recovery Girl looked at him again, a knowing look on her face.

“I know you’re eager for things to go back to normal”, she said calmly. “But I would take it easy, if I were you. You still have a long path of recovery ahead of you before you can go back to your routine”.

Katsuki sighed, leaning his head back on his pillow and staring at the ceiling.

“Whenever I think I’m getting close to being dismissed, you people throw more obstacles in my way”.

Recovery Girl responded with a tiny laugh.

“Oh, dear, you should have seen yourself a week ago. If you had, you would be thanking me for keeping you in a hospital bed for so long”, she shook her head. “But don’t worry. We have some news I think you’ll enjoy”.

That made Katsuki frown. He turned his head to look at her again, but she had her back turned to him now, crouched over his medical record.

“Who’s we?”, he asked with a frown, at the same time he felt something moving behind him. He flinched out of instinct, heart rate becoming fast, but when he turned his head to look at the ominous shadow looming by his bedside, he realized that it was just Aizawa sensei. He relaxed, letting out a breath he didn’t know he had been holding and ignoring the pain in both his arms from the way he had tensed them up. They still weren’t fully healed.

“I have news for you”, Aizawa sensei said instead of offering him a greeting, which made Katsuki frown and sag back against his pillows again.

“What the hell is it? Why do you two keep saying things mysteriously instead of getting to the damn point?”, he complained.

“Because you’re a stubborn student and your self-preservation isn’t one of the best”, Aizawa offered simply. “Also, I want to make sure you’re not about to pass out and forget everything I’m about to tell you. You know I don’t like repeating myself”.

Katsuki rolled his eyes, trying to pretend he wasn’t dying to know what the news were. He had an idea in mind, but he didn’t want to put the cart in front of the horses.

“I’m not going to pass out”, he guaranteed, and he would have crossed his arms above his chest if they weren’t stuck into casts. Yes, he was feeling a bit groggy, and yes, he was a little light-headed, but his willingness to find out about the news was stronger than those feelings. Especially if his assumption was right. “Just spit it out”, he told his teacher, trying to hide his eagerness. He was getting bored out of his mind in that hospital bed, and any change in routine would help stimulate his brain.

Aizawa gave him a look that was full of disbelief and doubt, but he leaned one of his legs against the side of Katsuki’s bed, arms crossed above his chest. He studied Katsuki’s face for a long moment, pensive.

“So”, he started. Katsuki could feel his heart beating fast inside his chest, but there was also a sense of calmness in it – as if there was something keeping him from becoming too anxious too fast. “You’ve been recovering well. The proof of that is that you were able to transfer back to UA and you’re no longer under the threat of imminent death”.

“That’s good to know”, Katsuki nodded sincerely.

Aizawa spared Recovery Girl a look.

“As Recovery Girl said, you still have a long path ahead of you”, he continued. “But you’ve been showing yourself to be pretty obedient and responsible when it comes to taking care of yourself. Which is why I have decided you can see Midoriya”.

Katsuki’s lips blossomed into a smile, and he bit his lower lip as he stared up at the ceiling of the room. Noticing that his teacher was witnessing this display of emotion, however, made him smother down the smile and go back to his usual grumpy face – but the damage was

done. Aizawa had seen his reaction, Recovery Girl had probably witnessed it too, and there was no point in denying that this was what he had been most eager for when they told him he was being transferred back to UA. He was going to see Deku. He was going to *talk* to him.

“I don’t think I need to remind you you’re not to over-exert yourself, or to get out of bed unattended, or to get in a fight, or to do anything that can set back your recovery”, Aizawa continued, stern. “Or else, I’m going to ban Midoriya from visiting for good and you’ll only be able to talk to him once you’re 100% cleared from Recovery Girl’s medical care, which, as we’ve said, is going to take a while”.

Katsuki nodded his head, complicit. He didn’t fancy being ordered around like that, but god, it had been weeks since he last saw Deku. He was dying to look at him, talk to him, even if he wouldn’t admit it. Plus, his bond with his teacher had become even stronger because of those nights he stayed and watched over him in the hospital. Katsuki knew he owed him not only respect, but also admiration.

“All right”, he said obediently. “When is he coming over?”

Aizawa spared a quick glimpse at the closed door of the medical area before he turned back to Katsuki.

“If you’re up to it, he’s waiting outside as we speak”, he provided. “Do you want to rest, or can I send him in? And Bakugou, I’m asking sincerely. I know you’re eager to see him, but if you’re too tired –“

“He can come in”, Katsuki interrupted his teacher without meaning to. Now that he knew Deku was just outside the door, he felt more awake and vivid than ever. He wouldn’t be able to go back to sleep, not when Deku was outside waiting for him. Moreover, he had to think about Deku, more than about himself. The nerd was probably dying to see him too, and Katsuki could only imagine the disappointment painting his face if he was dismissed after waiting for god knows how long to go inside that room.

Aizawa sighed at Katsuki’s fast response, and he had a look on his face that told Katsuki he was regretting making this choice. Still, he walked around the bed and towards the door, a bit too slowly for Katsuki’s taste, before gripping the doorhandle.

“I’ll talk to him and send him in”, Aizawa announced.

“I’ll give you two some space and go check my other patients”, Recovery Girl said right away, placing Katsuki’s medical chart back on its proper place and strolling slowly further into the medical area, at the same time Aizawa walked out of the room and closed the door behind himself.

Katsuki felt like he was a kid who had consumed too much sugar at once. His thoughts were rushing inside his head, and his heart was beating frantically inside his chest, even though there was something different about his usual sense of anxiety. He felt excited and attentive, but there was something containing him – keeping him at bay, in a way. He could still think rationally and carefully rather than getting lost on his unraveling thoughts.

The fact that he could think rationally didn't do much in his favor, though. Because as minutes passed by and nothing happened, Katsuki found himself wondering where the *fuck* was Deku. Seconds became minutes that became hours in his mind, and he couldn't keep his eyes off the damn door, waiting for it to open. Rationally, he could deduce that Aizawa sensei was probably giving Deku the same advice he had given Katsuki – don't fight, don't overexert, don't do anything stupid. But the passionate side of Katsuki – the one that usually was in control – kept screaming at him from inside his head, demanding to know where Deku was and what was taking him so long.

After everything that had happened, Katsuki shouldn't find it weird that he missed Deku and was eager to see him. The fact that, the last they had seen of each other in a sober state happened during a series of arguments and fights was also a good reason why Katsuki was so desperate to see the nerd. But it was still a bit hard, even after all that, to ignore that terrible gremlin-like part of his brain that kept trying to paint Deku as the enemy, as someone that he should fear or despise or hate or all of that at the same time.

The door opened.

Katsuki watched Deku with attention as he entered the room, but he could feel his whole body relax the minute he spotted the damn nerd. And damn, he looked like *hell*. His face was almost as pale as his corpse had been, all those months ago, but a blush raised to his cheeks in a very noticeable way as soon as he registered Katsuki's eyes glued to his form.

He walked into the room, shoulders tense and eyes fixed on Katsuki. He looked like he was trying to read Katsuki's expression and make sense of it, or maybe he was trying to figure out what he was supposed to say in a situation like that. The tension inside the room was nearly palpable at this point, and Katsuki could feel it growing with each step Izuku took. The nerd looked so scared and desperate for answers that Katsuki couldn't help but to wonder what the fuck Aizawa sensei had told him before he came in.

In his mind, he couldn't help but to compare the situation to Aizawa sensei giving Deku something similar to a "dad-talk". Which didn't make any sense, since Aizawa wasn't his dad and Deku wasn't his boyfriend. Katsuki didn't know why he had thought that. The thought embarrassed him.

Deku stopped in front of Katsuki's bed, at his feet. Katsuki just stared at him, waiting, and Deku stared back, pale and blushing and very, very silent.

Katsuki noticed Deku was carrying a notebook. His grip on it was so tight that his knuckles had gone white, and from the distance, Katsuki couldn't quite see what was written on the cover. From what he knew of the damn nerd in all those years they grew up together, he wouldn't doubt if the notebook consisted of all the things Deku wanted to tell him, listed down to the tiniest of details, with paragraphs and topic and bullet pointers and all that shit. He was clinging to it like a lifeline, so Katsuki could tell the thing was close to his heart, whatever its contents were.

Deku lowered his head, looking like he was stuck in a silent prayer for strength. Katsuki felt the imminent urge to break the silence between them for once and take the lead like he always did, but something stopped him.

Because this time, things were different. This time, he had worn Deku's shoes. This time, there seemed to be little to be said to comfort the boy, who was clearly emotional upon seeing Katsuki, and with reason to be so.

Deku took in a shaky breath and raised his chin, meeting Katsuki's eyes. Katsuki stared back at him, waiting. He hoped that his eyes were telling Deku his intended silent message: that he was giving him space to speak first, to get everything out of his chest. Katsuki was done arguing and fighting and all that shit. If they hadn't wasted so much time going through that loophole that all of their arguments seemed to turn into, there was a possibility that they would have managed to stop the villains before they had the time to set the bombs off. No, arguing had done nothing for them in the past; it wasn't about to start doing something in the present.

Deku took in another shaky breath, worrying at his lower lip for a moment.

"H-How are you?", was what the nerd decided to start with.

Katsuki blinked at him. He did nothing, he just blinked. Because Deku had spent so fucking long trying to formulate a sentence, and he had started off with the most basic question he could have gotten his hands on. Katsuki glanced at his arms, which were still enveloped by casts, before meeting Izuku's eyes again and narrowing them.

"Whatcha think?", he asked, rhetorical.

"I'm –", Deku swallowed dry, sounding like he genuinely regretted his choice of words. "I'm sorry".

A pregnant pause.

"Not your fault", Katsuki said. Because, if he knew something about the idiot in front of him, was that he had a tendency to blame himself for every single thing that happened, even if it had nothing to do with him. For someone who constantly belittled himself, Deku seemed to consider himself the center of the world a bit too often when it came to negative occasions.

Deku lowered his head again. Katsuki wished he could get his hands on a mind-reading quirk somehow, just so that he could tell what was going on inside the nerd's head.

"Are you – Are you in any pain?", he asked, staring at his own feet.

Right, so he'd keep playing it safe, then. Katsuki scoffed, but the sound wasn't loud enough for Deku to hear it from where he was standing at the bottom of the bed.

"It's better now. They still have me hooked to the pain meds, so I don't have much to complain about", he admitted.

"That's a first", Deku chuckled.

Katsuki raised his eyebrows at the sudden rebuttal. Deku was rarely this straightforward. And sure, Katsuki was done arguing, but what the fuck was going on with Deku? Had he suddenly grown balls twice as large to say this shit to Katsuki's face?

Spotting the look on Katsuki's face, and probably realizing how his words had sounded, Deku frowned and rushed to say:

"No, sorry. I didn't mean it like that".

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

"Well, you didn't tell any lies", he shrugged, ignoring the throbbing that the movement caused in his still healing arms and in his torso, despite the pain meds. His decision to take a pacifist stance in this conversation was probably going to raise some eyebrows, but he decided to stick to it – especially because he had a vague idea that Aizawa sensei would prohibit Deku from coming near him if they did have a fight.

Deku bit his lower lip. He went back to staring at Katsuki as if he was trying to read him, and, in return, Katsuki decided to show him that he was fine. From the amount of time that he spent stuck in a hospital bed, with hours to no end of spare time and nothing to do because of his two broken arms, Katsuki had a lot of time for introspection and self-realization during his recovery. And one thing that he realized was that he and Deku being at each other's throats over the same reasons all the time was equivalent to a dog chasing its own tail. It was useless, and pointless, and it helped no one. At first, it was kind of entertaining to external viewers, but eventually, everyone tired out of watching it.

No, Katsuki had almost died. He had almost lost his life in that wreckage, and he had been so fucked up that it was basically a miracle he was still breathing. So he would make something useful with this extra time he had earned. He would make it count. He wouldn't waste it on no repetitive arguments with Deku, he wouldn't throw it on the trash by being childishly proud. He would make the most of it. Wasting hours in Recovery Girl's medbay was the last instance in which he would ever spare his time to stupid things.

Which was why Deku's silence was slowly driving him mad. He seemed so hesitant and lost, Katsuki couldn't bear witnessing it any longer.

"Why are you giving me that look?", he asked, annoyed. Deku's blush deepened.

"W-What look?", he asked, defensive.

"I don't know", Katsuki admitted, shrugging. "But it's weird".

Deku closed his eyes for a moment. He seemed embarrassed.

"Sorry", he said. Katsuki twisted his nose.

"Stop apologizing", he reprimanded.

"Sorry for apologizing", Deku had the audacity to respond.

Katsuki sighed in disbelief.

"*Seriously*, Deku?", he asked, annoyed.

Deku lowered his head again. Katsuki watched him with a growing sense of impatience and a hint of disappointment. He seemed like he was struggling to organize his thoughts, to get to the point. Katsuki could feel his irritation growing inside of him and starting to smother the pacifist thoughts of *no fighting, no arguing.*

"I just –", Deku started. "I just got a lot in my mind right now", he justified.

Katsuki scoffed in spite of himself.

"You think *I* don't? I've been lying in bed doing nothing all day for over a week now", he pointed out with impatience.

Deku finally raised his head at this, looking at Katsuki with a surprised expression. Katsuki blinked a few times and tried to wrap his head around his mantra of *no arguing.*

" – *But* that has also given me a lot of time to think", he added. "About some stuff".

Deku eyed him.

"About… some stuff?"

Katsuki nodded.

"I think I can say the same about you, if that notebook you've got there is what I think it is", he pointed out.

Deku stared at the notebook he was holding, mouth opening and closing like a fish's as he tried to figure out what to say and failed.

"I – How –", he stuttered.

"We know each other since we were brats", Katsuki pointed out. "When you think, you write. When you overthink, you overwrite. It's what you do".

Deku blushed again. He walked up from the foot of the bed towards the chair sitting next to Katsuki's head, notebook tight on his grip and free hand flexing in and out of a fist. He was clearly nervous, but Katsuki couldn't really understand why. Fine, he had almost died, and Deku was the only one who they kept from visiting him so far. But that was a reason for him to be stressed, irritated, frustrated, etc. Not *nervous*. "Nervous" told Katsuki that there was more into this conversation, more that Deku wanted him to know. And Katsuki just wished that he would get to the fucking point at once.

"You're right", Deku said, nodding. "I did write some of my thoughts".

"Some of them", Katsuki repeated in a deadpan. The whole notebook was just *some* of them?

"Some of them, yeah", Deku nodded. "And I wanted to go over them with you, if you don't mind. Not all of them at once, of course, because you're still recovering and I don't want to end up causing any kind of setback on that –"

“Deku”, Katsuki cut him short. Time was precious, and he didn’t have enough for this.

“Yeah?”, Deku replied hesitantly, but with attention.

“Just tell me what you need to tell me”, Katsuki instructed. “Don’t you dare sugarcoat me because I’m – like this”, he nodded at his body, broken and recovering. If this was the reason why Deku was beating around the bush instead of speaking his mind… Katsuki wouldn’t be able to maintain his pacifist mantra. He hated being looked down on, and Deku should know that better than anyone.

Deku averted his gaze from Katsuki for a moment.

“I can’t do it all at once”, he admitted. “Not all of it”.

Katsuki stared at him through squinted, doubtful eyes. Deku stared back, eyes sincere. He seemed like he was telling the truth.

“I have to do it slowly”, he continued, honest. “If not for your sake, then for mine”.

Katsuki stared at him for a few more instants. It really was a whole notebook of information, and going through it all would take a while. Maybe Deku was just trying to optimize their time, after all, which was something Katsuki could agree with.

He nodded. This was better than arguing, anyway.

“All right”, he said.

Izuku frowned, seeming confused.

“You’re… Not mad about it?”

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“Deku, take a good hard look at me”, he said, slightly annoyed. “I’m bored out of my damn mind and I can’t even drink a glass of water without someone else helping me because of my damn arms”, he nodded at himself again. “If you really wrote a notebook-worth of subjects you want to discuss and you want to take it slowly, then go ahead. If we do this bit by bit at least you’ll keep me entertained for more than one day”.

Deku blinked at him.

“O…k”, he complied, shifting the notebook from hand to hand. He seemed surprised, but no longer so reluctant “So, how do you want to do this?”

Katsuki scoffed in irritation again.

“Tch. You tell me, you’re the one with the notes”.

Deku narrowed his eyes at him in suspicion.

“Ok, what’s wrong?”

Katsuki gave up on being nice and glared at Deku. The nerd was the one acting all weird for no apparent reason and *Katsuki* was the one who had something wrong? Really?

“What are you *talking* about?”, he demanded.

“Something’s off”, Deku said bluntly, almost accusingly. “But I can’t figure out what it is”.

“Well, welcome to my life”, Katsuki snorted, annoyed. “That’s everyday with you”.

Deku gave him a look.

“That’s not true”.

Fucking great. It was pointless to try being nice with Deku, wasn’t it? It was like he was begging for a damn conflict.

“Are we going back to arguing already?”, Katsuki rolled his eyes, purposefully accusing.

That seemed to shut Deku up. He stared at Katsuki with a shocked expression, mouth slightly agape, before he sealed his lips and tilted his chin up defiantly.

“No”, he said decisively. “No, we’re not arguing today”.

Katsuki tilted his head in evident disbelief. That was what he was trying to do, with no success, even if Deku didn’t realize it.

“I doubt it”, he said, just to be a tease.

“You shouldn’t. Because whenever I realize we’re about to start arguing I’m going to take a step back and go out for some air before we actually get to it”, Deku announced.

Katsuki scoffed. So as it turns out, Deku had his own little version of *no fighting, no arguing* plan all written down and ready to go, didn’t he? Then why the fuck did he keep insisting on this shit instead of just talking to Katsuki already?

“You’re gonna be taking a lot of steps back then”, Katsuki muttered, irritated.

“If that becomes necessary, then yes”, Deku had the audacity to say.

Katsuki scoffed again. Fine, the plan would be for the best, anyway. If Deku actually stepped out to take a breather whenever their conversation started to get too heated, their chances of wasting their time arguing would decrease monumentally. Maybe this way they could finally sit down and talk, now that there was a failsafe to their dynamics. Aizawa sensei wouldn’t have to banish Deku again, and Katsuki would finally get to spend time with the nerd doing something other than debating and fighting constantly. Sounded like a plan.

“So?”, Katsuki encouraged Deku to continue when he said nothing else.

“You’re ok with this?”, Deku asked back, like he couldn’t quite believe that Katsuki was mature enough to accept it. For some reason, that disbelief pissed him off. Couldn’t Deku see he was trying his damn earnest?

“What the fuck am I going to do if I’m not ok with this?”, Katsuki asked. “I can’t exactly hold you by the hand and keep you from going out if that’s what you want”.

Deku stared at him. Katsuki couldn’t quite read the look on his face, but he gripped his notebook with two hands and put on a decided face.

“Fine”, he swallowed. “Can we get to it?”

“Go ahead”, Katsuki shrugged again.

Deku sat down on the chair destined to visitors by the bed, and stared at Katsuki for a few more moments before awkwardly opening his notebook.

“Ok”, he said, more to himself than to Katsuki, eyes darting across the first page of the notebook. Katsuki made a face.

“Are you gonna read?”

“What?”, Deku looked at him and frowned, confused.

“Are you gonna read everything you wrote down?”, Katsuki clarified, looking at the notebook with something akin to dread. He knew how much Deku wrote on those things. They would spend the entire day and night there reading it, even if Deku opted to take things slowly.

“No”, Deku said, but he sounded hesitant and weak. Katsuki saw right through his lie.

“You were gonna”, he accused.

“No, I wasn’t”, Deku tried again, a bit more determined this time.

Katsuki sighed.

“Just get this over with already, Deku. I have stuff I want to say, too”, he admitted.

Deku looked at him with a surprised expression.

“You do?”

Katsuki rolled his eyes. So what, Deku thought he had almost died and spent days waiting for him to visit him on his deathbed and he had nothing to say? He thought Katsuki had hallucinated him in the debris with Kaminari and he was going to keep his mouth shut about it?

“Yeah”, he said like it was obvious.

And then, Deku had the audacity to reply:

“Do you… want to go first, or…?”

Katsuki huffed, angry.

“I ain’t going first”.

“That’s unusual, coming from you”, Deku accused, and Katsuki knew, he *knew*, that Deku had a point, but his pride spoke louder.

“Shut the hell up”, he snorted. “I’m just letting you go first because you have a whole ass notebook. I want to get it out of the way”.

Deku lowered his head.

“Fine. Ok”.

“Whenever you’re ready”, Katsuki said mockingly, with malice.

Deku took another deep breath.

“So”, he cleared his throat, eyes back on the notebook. “First of all, we need to talk about what happened”.

“Ok”, Katsuki nodded. They really *did* need to talk about that.

“About how the… the building fell, and everything. And things that happened after that. Would you be ok with that?”

“Yeah”.

“You sure?”, Deku insisted. He sounded like one of those hospital people asking for his consent before doing a procedure.

“Yeah”, Katsuki said a bit more emphatically, before he lost his temper again. “Go ahead”.

Deku shifted on his seat.

“Ok. So, um. I need to tell you something, and I need you to not be mad about it”.

Katsuki squinted in suspicion.

“Because you’re gonna storm out if I do?”, he asked teasingly.

“I’ll have to walk away for a bit until you cool down, yes”, Deku nodded with sincerity, not sensing the malice hidden in the teasing comment.

Katsuki sniffed. He had a serious look on his face, and so did Deku. They were finally getting down to business.

“Fine”, he complied.

“Ok”, Deku nodded.

Silence. Deku didn’t continue. He looked frozen, like his brain had stopped processing information.

“So…? You planning on doing it today, or…?”, Katsuki teased.

“IwentafteryouwhileyouwereburiedbytherubbleandIsortofkeptyoualiveuntilhelparrived”.

A pause.

“What?”, Katsuki frowned, not understanding one word.

“I… went after you”, Deku swallowed. “After the building fell on you. I broke the police’s barricade and climbed my way into the building to find you. And I stayed with you until help arrived. The whole structure started to collapse on us while we were getting you out, so I – I used my quirk to smash the rubble away”.

Katsuki’s brain was the one that stopped processing information this time.

“I came to the hospital with you, but – Kacchan?”, Deku called, worried, upon seeing the look on Katsuki’s face. He was frowning in confusion, taken aback by what he had heard. The whole thing was bad and so Deku-like it shouldn’t be surprising, but there was one detail, one word, that slapped him in the face.

“What do you mean you used your quirk?”, he asked, totally taken aback. Because he could remember, using One For All and increasing his power and the orange lightning that ran across his skin. He could remember the rush, the time slowing down, the feeling of omnipotence. How the fuck could Deku have used his quirk if Katsuki didn’t pass it back to him?

“Yes, you probably don’t remember but I have my quirk back, we’ll get to that –“, Izuku tried to dismiss the subject, which no, Katsuki wasn’t having.

“What do you *mean* you have your quirk back? How?”, he insisted, confused.

Deku sighed.

“I’ll – I’ll explain”, he promised. “But there’s stuff I wanted to discuss first”.

It was Katsuki’s turn to sigh. Honestly? It was impossible to be a pacifist with this piece of shit.

“Then why did you start with that?”, he demanded, angry.

“I forgot you forgot!”

“Well, then explain!”

“I will, but there’s stuff I want to talk about first!”

“For *fuck’s* sake!”

“Sorry!”, Izuku pleaded, sounding sincere.

A pause. They were both breathing heavily.

“So, um. I wanted to get that out of the way”, Deku said awkwardly, averting his eyes back to the notebook so that he wouldn’t have to look at Katsuki’s angry face.

“You did”, Katsuki spat in a resented tone.

“And you’re not mad about it?”, Izuku asked tentatively, clearly hesitant.

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“Are you gonna keep asking that every time you say something slightly risky?”, he asked with annoyance.

Deku sustained his gaze this time, honest and open.

“I just want to make sure you’re not holding on to any negative emotion before we go on”.

Katsuki scoffed. *Negative emotion.* All his fucking emotions seemed to be negative, these days. Scratch that: all his emotions had been negative from the day he was born. The only positive emotions he had felt were when he had been stuck with Deku’s shitty ghost, but he couldn’t really admit that without sounding like a loser. So he opted for the easy way out of this.

“Well, I can remember some flashes of you and the rubble, so it actually makes sense you were there with me”, he admitted. Now that he thought about it, Deku’s presence could be as real as Kaminari’s blood-covered face shouting at him.

He had been so taken aback by the revelation of One For All being back with Deku that he didn’t really focus on everything else. The fact that he had broken a fucking police barricade just to go after him? Radical AF. Katsuki would have trouble admitting this aloud, but he didn’t expect any less from Deku. The stupid motherfucker had always lacked a proper sense of self-preservation, and he had always shown a tendency to become feral when Katsuki’s wellbeing was on the line. He supposed he was a bit pissed that Deku had risked himself in that way, bursting into a fallen wreckage like that, but he was clearly fine. Katsuki had the option of scolding him for something that had happened weeks ago, or he could let it go to make the conversation move forwards faster. He could always go back to it in the future, he supposed.

“I can’t remember much else, though”, he said. “And I’m not mad because you’re obviously fine, so whatever reason I had to freak out is now over. It’s not like you’re hurt, right?”, he asked just to be sure.

“No, I’m not”, Deku provided. “I did break my arm when I smashed. But –“, he added quickly before Katsuki could protest. “It’s fine now! I’m fine!”

Katsuki stared at him through narrowed eyes. Ok, now he was more pissed. Deku should know better than to go around breaking his fucking arms, and he should know better than to do it for Katsuki’s sake. He didn’t want any part in that guilt, he didn’t want that weight on his shoulders, if Deku fucked his arms up so badly he couldn’t use them anymore.

But he was dying to know about One For All. He really needed to fucking know how and when he had passed it back to Deku, and so, in this strong sense of urgency, he decided not to comment, as if not to stall their conversation any further. *I’ll certainly go back to this later, you damn nerd,* he made a silent promise to himself, just because he knew he couldn’t let this subject go so easily.

“Ok”, Deku sniffed. “So now that’s out of the way –“

“You’re gonna tell me how you got your quirk back?”, Katsuki suggested.

“ – I’m gonna go back a little”, Deku said instead.

Katsuki eyerolled.

“Back to the time we were kids”, Deku added.

Katsuki frowned.

“*That* far?”, Katsuki demanded angrily.

“Yes”, Deku nodded firmly.

Katsuki really wished his arms were functional, because he wanted to rub his face and pull at his hair. Here he was, dying to know crucial information about All Might’s legacy and his quirk, and Deku wanted to rant about childhood memories and hurt feelings and that shit. For *fuck’s* sake.

“Ugh. At least tell me if you have your damn memories back, now”, Katsuki demanded, because that was something that he couldn’t wait to know any longer. He needed to know if that amnesia hell was over. He needed to know –

“I do”, Deku nodded promptly.

Katsuki stared at him with resentment in his eyes. Deku had strolled in and ranted about meaningless shit so far. The one important subject he brought up, he wanted to leave for later. He didn’t think of telling Katsuki he had his ghost memories back? When that had been a crucial part of their lives and of the trauma they seemed to be piling up in their heads?

“Great. Were you going to mention that or…?”, he asked angrily, bitterly.

“We’ll get there eventually”, Deku pointed out sternly, as if he was the one giving orders. “So”, he cleared his throat again. “You hated me. Right?”

Katsuki continued to stare at him with disbelief and resentment, but Deku didn't seem to realize that. He really wanted to say something regarding One For All and the ghost memories, but for some reason, under Deku's stern gaze… he felt like he would end up sounding like a petty child. What he needed to do in order to prevent an argument was to keep the conversation flowing naturally, until Deku ran out of bullet pointers to give and Katsuki could get a hold of the fucking answers he longed for so badly.

"Not when we were brats", he admitted, playing Deku's game. "That came later. When we were kids, I liked having you around. You were always chasing after me and giving me praise".

Deku nodded.

"The hatred came when you found out I was quirkless, right?"

Katsuki thought back for a moment.

"Nah", he shook his head. "You being quirkless just made me feel even better about myself".

Deku tapped his feet on the floor unrhythmically.

"So when did you start hating me?", he asked curiously. This was such a heavy subject to be discussed, but Deku was approaching it so naturally and so easily that Katsuki decided to return the courtesy.

"I don't know", he admitted with a shrug. "It just happened one day".

"It just *happened*?", Deku snorted, smiling at Katsuki's statement.

"Yeah", Katsuki shrugged. "One day I realized I couldn't stand your face anymore. I didn't put much thought into it. It was more of a feeling", he admitted.

Deku's lips formed a thin line. He looked away for a moment before lowering his head and looking at Katsuki again.

"Yeah, you see, I don't think that's it", he said with an apologetic expression.

Katsuki blinked.

"What?", he asked. Was Deku trying to school him about his own damn feelings?

"I don't think that's it", Deku shook his head. "I don't think you actually hated me".

Katsuki stared at him. He decided that he would end up starting an argument if he spoke up, so instead he simply stared at Deku with a blank expression.

"I mean, well, yes, you had to hate me to do those things you did, but I think –", Deku continued. "I think you cared", he resumed with a hopeful shrug.

Silence. Deku's eyes were fixed on Katsuki's.

“I think you always cared”, he concluded, the hint of a smile appearing on his lips.

Katsuki hated the idea of wiping that pleased look off Deku’s face, but he couldn’t let him keep living in a lie, either.

He sighed heavily, shaking his head.

“Deku –“

“No, hear me out –“, Deku tried to say, desperate to be right.

“Deku, the shit I did to you –“, Katsuki started.

“Hear me out –“

“That wasn’t because I cared –“, he tried to say.

“Let me explain –“, Deku attempted.

“And we’ve gone over this and I *thought* you had already forgiven me –“, Katsuki pointed out, a bit angry.

“Let me *explain*”, Deku said emphatically. “I’m not saying you cared about me. I’m saying you cared what I thought”.

Katsuki stared at him. He didn’t want to crush whatever fantasy Deku had created in his mind, but he didn’t want to feed this hypothesis, either. However, before he could continue, Deku went back to yapping his mouth off.

“You cared what I thought about you, even if I was just some quirkless kid who used to be friends with you. And I think you hated how much my opinion mattered to you, especially because you were always boasting about not caring what anyone thought”.

Katsuki looked away in silence, a serious yet pensive look on his face. Deku was kind of right – Katsuki did care what he thought of him. How could he not? Out of all his so-called friends, Deku had always been the loudest and most constant in his admiration for Katsuki, going around showering him with praises and compliments no matter what he did. As a child, Katsuki had been addicted to it. And yeah, he always got a little angry when he did something awesome and Deku was too busy looking the other way, or when he did something awful – like making a kid cry – and Deku reprimanded him for it. It was a fact that Deku’s opinion was something Katsuki had always cared about, but that wasn’t the origin of his hatred for him.

“Do you agree with me? Be honest”, Deku urged.

Katsuki glared at him.

“I’m *always* honest”.

“Not always”, Deku gave him a look.

Katsuki turned to him, fury in his crimson eyes. Impulse, hot and burning, overwhelmed him, and before he knew better the words had already left his mouth.

"Because right now you're a quirkless loser, and you'll end up getting yourself killed again".

"Tch", Katsuki clicked his tongue, glaring away. Fine. Maybe not always.

A pause.

"I don't think that's it", Katsuki admitted eventually. "I mean, I *did* care what you thought and it pissed me off that I did. But I didn't hate you because of that".

Deku kept looking at him. Katsuki met his eyes.

"I hated you because I was a different person. Because I used to think people were no better than their quirks were, I used to think quirks were the only valuable thing to consider. I used to believe that not having a quirk meant having no use to society, and the fact that you behaved as if you were my equal even though you were quirkless pissed me off. Soon enough everything you did or said pissed me off, and then not even your constant praise made up for the irritation. I only cared what you thought because I wanted you to know your place".

Deku stared at him for a few more moments before looking down, at his own feet. He looked a bit disappointed by the answer, but not completely surprised by it.

"But you don't hate me anymore", it was an affirmation.

A pause.

Did he really have to ask that? Wasn't it obvious by now?

"No", Katsuki responded anyway, because if Deku still needed to know, that meant he wasn't doing a proper job in demonstrating it.

"And you don't think like that anymore", Deku continued.

"You know damn well I don't", Katsuki said firmly. He wanted Deku to get it, once and for all.

"Right. Um, ok", Deku nodded, clearly awkward. He wasn't looking Katsuki in the eye anymore, and a tense silence filled the room. Deku fiddled with his notes, trying to figure out how to continue.

"There's – um, there's still a lot I want to say to you, and I can't say everything all at once and today, so the next big topic is – erm. It's One For All", he said, sending a spike of anxiety through Katsuki's chest.

"Which you mysteriously got back from me with no explanation", he pointed out maliciously.

"Yes – I'll get to that in a moment", Deku promised. "But first I want to go over something more important, and for that I'm grateful you don't hate me anymore otherwise this would be

really awkward".

"Just say what you mean, nerd", Katsuki snorted, trying to pretend he wasn't feeling wary because of that last comment.

Deku's mouth opened and closed. Katsuki wished he would stop doing that.

"When – When a holder transfers One For All", he begun, mouth dry. "Their – essence, or something like that – a… vestige of them. It stays with the quirk. It's passed along with it. Right?"

"Right", Katsuki nodded, remembering All Might's explanation.

"Well", Deku continued. "That means the previous holder can still use the quirk even after it's passed on. All Might fought All For One using only the embers after he passed it on to me, for example".

Katsuki blinked several times, taking in what he had just been told. What Deku was telling him.

What the fuck.

"So you're saying –"

"I think you'll still be able to use it", Deku continued before Katsuki could finish. "Later. When you're better".

Silence.

Katsuki was becoming overwhelmed with different emotions. Deku's quirk still lived in him. All Might's quirk still lived in him. What the fuck was he supposed to do? He had never been a part of their dirty little secret until a while ago, he had never wanted to partake into this. He got himself into this mess by accident, because he had been an idiot and Deku had been an idiot and they ended up making a mistake that almost cost the damn nerd's life.

Katsuki had accidentally ended up being the only person who could save Deku from certain death; that was the reason why he took his quirk. And he had taken One For All from Deku under the promise that he would be nothing other than a receptacle, a temporary keeper of his power, a provisional holder that would give it back to Deku when he was well enough to take it and be done with it. He wasn't meant it to keep it forever. He wasn't meant to have it *live on* within him.

"I don't want it –", he started.

"I know you don't", Deku said, sounding weirdly comprehensive.

A pause.

"I don't *need* it", Katsuki corrected himself, and it sounded like he was saying those words more to himself than to Deku.

“I *know* you don’t –“, Deku tried.

“But now I’m *stuck* with it?”, Katsuki accused. His feelings were nervousness mixed with indignation and anger, but mostly anger. He didn’t fucking want to have his own explosive quirk maculated by One For All. He didn’t want to become number one and achieve greatness because of All Might’s borrowed power turned permanent. He didn’t want to always live with that little doubt nagging at the back of his head, *did I accomplish this because of my power or because of Deku’s?*

Deku sighed.

“Listen – I’m sorry. About that. But that’s not all”, he said in a weird tone of voice, as if the worst was yet to come.

Katsuki raised an eyebrow. That’s not *all?* Like, there was more? His heart, which had been pretty controlled so far, was starting to do some weird leaps inside his chest, which couldn’t really be a good sign. Deku, on the other hand, sighed, his shoulders sagging.

“Maybe I should remind you *not* to freak out for the sake of your recovery –“, he started, sensing Katsuki’s nervousness. Katsuki, in response, huffed out an annoyed breath.

“All this stalling *is* making me freak out, so unless you want a blanket wrapped around your throat –“, he began to threaten, a little bit back to his usual mood.

“That’s not all”, Deku repeated. The more frantic Katsuki became, the more leveled Deku seemed to get in response. One of them had to be the rational one, Katsuki supposed. “I mean. When a holder passes One For All on, they also… please don’t freak out – but they also pass on their own quirk”, Deku said, an apologetic tone in his voice.

Katsuki’s face was blank for a second, and then all the blood drained from it out of a sudden. His eyes became wide with unmistakable fear as realization dawned upon him.

“Are – Are you saying I’m –“

“Kacchan –“

“I’m – I’m *quirkless*? Is that what you’re saying?”

Katsuki tried to organize his thoughts, but it was becoming harder and harder to do that with each panicked breath he took. Suddenly, his dreams and his panic attack from back at the hospital started to make sense. He hadn’t been able to use his quirk in them, as if he didn’t have it anymore. What if he *didn’t have it anymore*? Was that what Deku was saying? The way the nerd’s face became pale in response to Katsuki’s questioning did nothing to reassure his racing heart.

“N-No”, Deku said quickly, nervous. “I mean, I don’t know, but I wouldn’t think so –“

Wouldn’t think so? What was that supposed to tell him? Deku didn’t even know if he had made Katsuki quirkless on accident, and wouldn’t that be fucking ironical? He, Katsuki, becoming quirkless because he saved the life of Deku, the kid he had always mocked because

of his lack of a quirk. It would be too much of a coincidence for Katsuki to believe it, except this was exactly the type of ironical thing that would happen to him, right? First, his hearing, now, his quirk.

He had passed his quirk to Deku. Deku fucking had it now. They had fucking swapped quirks, except Deku continued to have multiple ones, whereas Katsuki was left with the one he never even wanted in the first place.

He couldn't keep living in doubt. He couldn't wait until he was better to test that theory, he didn't want to wait. Recovery Girl hadn't announced how long it would take until she fixed his arms for good, but Katsuki knew that no answer to that question would be satisfactory. He needed to know if he was quirkless. He needed to know it *now*.

Katsuki raised one of his casted hands and stared at it. Then, with wide eyes and a harsh intake of breath, he activated his quirk, wincing in pain when he successfully created an explosion that cracked the cast covering his arm and sent a wave of piercing pain up to his shoulder.

"Kacchan!", Deku let go of his notebook and jumped at him, grabbing his now exposed broken hand.

Katsuki held his breath, trying to swallow the pain down and stop his racing heart from jumping out of his chest. "What on earth were you thinking?!"

"I needed to know", Katsuki said through gritted teeth, a grimace painting his now sweaty face. He didn't expect Deku to understand his reasons. "I just needed to know, Deku".

"I didn't mean you were quirkless!", Deku shouted, nervous. He was still holding Katsuki's broken hand. "You shouldn't have done that!"

"At least my quirk's still here", he groaned, feeling light-headed. The pain was so intense it drew the colors from the room; everything was becoming black and white and his vision was becoming doubled. Deku immediately reached forward and pressed the buzzer to call a nurse.

"Yeah, and now your hand is worse! You could have waited until it was healed –", Deku started, but Katsuki wasn't having it.

"I just needed to know, dammit!", he snapped, angry. Didn't Deku fucking understand that he couldn't afford to wait for days until he had an answer, not about this?

"So much for saying you don't think quirks are everything!", Deku accused, sounding angry.

Katsuki narrowed his tear-filled eyes and pointed Deku with a furious look.

"It's easier said than done; you spent your whole life without one!", he accused back.

Deku didn't know what it was like. As a kid, Katsuki had been praised and put on a pedestal for his quirk. He had been called strong, and marvelous, and incredible, and amazing, and so he decided that all those adjectives were associable with powerful quirks. The truth was,

Katsuki didn't know what he would be if he didn't have his explosion quirk – it had shaped most of his personality throughout his life.

He didn't expect Deku to understand his fear. The nerd's quirk had been earned late into his life; he had the chance to grow up knowing what it was like to not have everything he did associated to his quirk. Instead of understanding this, however, Deku continued to argue:

"Yeah, so I know its value more than anyone!", he pointed out, still angry but clearly worried.

"Well, and I know –", Katsuki started to argue, but he was interrupted by a familiar voice.

"What is going on in here? Midoriya?", it was Aizawa sensei, accompanied by a nurse. The woman rushed to Katsuki's side at the sight of his destroyed cast and his broken hand, which was still being held by Deku.

"Sensei", Deku said in horror, eyes darting between Katsuki's broken hand and his teacher. He looked like he had been caught red-handed doing something very, very wrong, and he let go of Katsuki's hand so that the nurse could take a look at it. "I – I –"

"You, me, out", Aizawa ordered simply. Then, he pointed a finger at Katsuki. "Bakugou, don't do anything stupid until I come back".

Katsuki swallowed past the pain and spared his teacher a desperate glance. In his terrified rush to confirm whether or not he had lost his quirk, he hadn't even considered the possibility that his teacher would find out he activated it, despite not being completely healed. He hadn't considered the possibility that Aizawa sensei would *ban* Deku from visiting, as if Katsuki's actions were somehow the nerd's fault.

He didn't want that. He couldn't bare that.

"Wait –", Kacchan tried to protest, but was stopped by a wince as the nurse checked on his broken hand.

"Midoriya. Out. Now", Aizawa instructed again in a tone that left no place for a discussion.

Deku spared Katsuki one final apologetic look before stepping out after his teacher. Aizawa held the door open for him and studied Katsuki with tired eyes before he stepped out as well and closed the door behind them.

"Dear, dear, why did you go and do that for?", the nurse asked him gently, analyzing his hand. "I'll have to remove what's left of the cast and replace it with a fresh one. Try to keep your hand still while I gather what I need and get Recovery Girl, all right?"

Katsuki didn't bother to reply to her. Instead, he tilted his head backwards and started blinking compulsively until the tears in his eyes dissipated and evaporated into nothingness. The nurse walked away and came back faster than he had expected her to, Recovery Girl following her close behind. She spared one analytical look towards Katsuki before she pushed a small step she could hop on and get on the same level as the bed. She grabbed his exposed hand without hesitating, and Katsuki couldn't hold back a hiss of pain.

Recovery Girl glared at him.

“Is this some sort of game for you?”

“What?”, Katsuki frowned.

“Do you think before you act, boy? Why would you use your quirk if your hands are still broken and healing?”, she scolded.

“I – I wasn’t thinking straight”, Katsuki admitted, just because he knew he was in the wrong this time and he didn’t want Recovery Girl to think he was stupid. “Must be all these meds y’all keep giving me”, he added, trying to shift the blame.

Recovery Girl sighed.

“Trust me, if you’re in pain *with* the medication, I wouldn’t want to be in your skin if you were off it”, she said with disapproval, inspecting Katsuki’s purple hand. “I’m going to heal your hand just enough for it to go back to what it was this morning. You don’t have enough stamina for me to heal it completely yet. But I expect you’ve learned your lesson better than to do it again, or else you’ll have to heal those arms in your own natural time”.

Katsuki opened his mouth to respond, but before he could, Recovery Girl kissed his hand and applied her quirk. He immediately felt exhausted and worn out – as she had said, his stamina was still very low because of the constant overuse of it to heal his impalement and his head injury. His energy was drained as his fingers and hand bones cracked back into their proper place, and Katsuki felt his eyes droop as his body sagged back into his hospital bed.

“I’ll come check on you later”, Recovery Girl said, but her voice was distant, as if she was talking from rooms away. “For now, just rest, you irresponsible child”.

Katsuki closed his eyes, sighing out a breath of relief. His hand felt better. So much better, he could barely cling on to consciousness…

He heard the distant sound of a door opening and closing, but he was so, so tired. The only reason he brought himself to open his eyes was because the name *Deku* popped into his foggy brain, and the possibility that the boy could be back was enough to motivate him into fighting against the sleepiness. But when he glimpsed at the door, all he saw was Aizawa, face stern and arms crossed. No Deku beside him. No Deku anywhere.

Katsuki felt sad.

“Sen… sei…”, he slurred, worn out. Aizawa stepped further into the room, disapproval and worry mixed together in equal proportions all over his face.

“Sleep”, Aizawa instructed in his teacher tone, which left no place for a discussion. “We’ll talk about this later”.

His primary instinct was to disobey and argue, but the tiredness got the best of him.

When he woke up, he was alone, and his head was facing the empty visitor's chair.

The first thing he noticed was that there was a notebook there. Deku's notebook. The events from before – when had that been? Yesterday? Or mere hours ago? – flooded his memory, and he sighed heavily as he stared at his hand. It was enveloped in a fresh cast and it no longer ached or throbbed, even though the skin still looked purplish beneath the white of the cast and the fingers were a bit crooked.

He ignored the dull ache he felt as he tried his best to sit up. He didn't know what to do about the notebook, but from the way Deku had been clinging to it and consulting it as if it was a conversation script, he presumed there must be a lot of personal shit in it.

Which left him with a moral question. Should he pick it up and read it? Or should he act as if he hadn't seen it in the first place? He was sure that, if he read it – if he managed to decipher and make sense of Deku's innermost thoughts, splayed in the pages of that notebook – he would find a way to be closer to what was going on in Deku's heart. Because that was one of the issues that sent them in that never ending loop of arguing and fighting, right? Katsuki did things with the best of intentions, with protective intentions, and Deku got it all wrong. His feelings – and Katsuki's, as well – kept getting constantly hurt because they didn't know what was going on inside each other's brains. So yeah, reading Deku's notebook might finally break the cycle of misunderstandings between them; it might finally shine a new light on their relationship and on the way Deku's brain worked. If Katsuki knew how Deku thought, he would know how to talk to him without causing an argument.

On the other hand, reading the notebook felt like an invasion of privacy. Katsuki didn't know what the boy had written down, or the nature and confidentiality of his annotations. There could be private shit in there. And sure, yeah, they had spent a month glued together with little to no privacy at all, so Deku kind of owed him in the privacy field. But Katsuki could also picture the hurt and the mistrust in Deku's expressive green eyes the *moment* Katsuki revealed – whether by accident or not – that he had read his personal notes. And hurting Deku – again – was the last thing Katsuki wanted to do.

The dilemma was settled by the door opening and revealing Aizawa sensei. Whatever thoughts Katsuki had on getting up and getting the notebook evaporated as soon as he saw the teacher. If anything, he was glad he spent so long trying to make up his mind, because this way he avoided to be caught red-handed reading it. Aizawa raised an eyebrow upon noticing Katsuki was awake, and approached the bed slowly, carefully.

"Bakugou", he greeted, stern as always.

“Sensei”, Katsuki greeted back, thankful that his speech was no longer slurred by sleep and medication.

Aizawa studied his face for a few moments, before walking over to the visitor’s chair. He stared down at it and found Deku’s notebook, which he picked up carefully and analyzed with attentive eyes.

“Midoriya forgot his notebook”, he commented, to which Katsuki nodded.

“He left in a hurry when you called him”, he justified.

Aizawa hummed and nodded his head.

“So, are you ready to tell me what that was all about?”, he looked back at Katsuki, notebook still in hands.

Katsuki bit at his inner cheeks.

“Didn’t Deku tell you?”

“I’m sorry?”, Aizawa raised an eyebrow.

“You kicked him out of here and stepped out with him”, Katsuki pointed out. “I thought you two had talked”.

Aizawa sensei blinked at him slowly, like a cat who was trying to decide whether or not to jump at its prey.

“We did talk”, Aizawa said. “But I’d like to hear your version of the facts”.

Katsuki sighed. Out of a sudden, he felt like a prisoner being interrogated. He should have known this conversation was coming, but in his defense, he passed out from exhaustion minutes after Aizawa sensei left and woke up minutes before he arrived again. He didn’t have much conscious time to figure his shit out and plan for a story, or at least a believable excuse.

Because he couldn’t explain what had truly happened, could he? He couldn’t just say “oh, I was afraid I accidentally lost my quirk when I returned One For All to Deku”. That was a no-go. So he needed to say something that wasn’t quite the truth, but wasn’t quite a lie, either – otherwise, he was sure his sensei would see right through it.

Katsuki took a deep breath, feeling heat rise to his face. It was an anticipation of the mortification he was sure he was about to feel.

“When… When I was back at the hospital”, he started, not looking at Aizawa. “And I had that dream about you”.

Silence.

“Right”, Aizawa nodded.

Katsuki tilted his head, sighing.

“I couldn’t use my quirk in the dream. To defend myself. And later, when I freaked out –“

“When you had the panic attack”, Aizawa corrected.

Katsuki scoffed.

“I thought there was something wrong with my quirk, too. So when Deku started talking about quirks and all that crap, I… I had to test mine. To find out if I still had it, if things were ok with it”.

He finally raised his eyes to look at Aizawa. He had a firm look on his face, a serious one.

“So Midoriya triggered you”, he concluded.

Katsuki rolled his eyes and huffed out a breath.

“He didn’t do it on purpose. He didn’t know about the dream, or about the panic attack. It wasn’t his fault, it was mine. I’m the one who lost my shit”.

Aizawa narrowed his eyes at his student.

“That’s an uncommon sight”.

“What is?”

“You, defending Midoriya. Taking the fall for him. Even after everything you went through”.

Katsuki sighed.

“That’s because it really wasn’t his fault. And I’m not a liar, I’m telling the truth. He isn’t to blame”.

Aizawa hummed low in his throat, nodding. He looked at the notebook again, before averting his eyes back to Katsuki.

“Did you read it?”, he asked plainly.

Katsuki sustained his teacher’s gaze.

“No”, he said.

Aizawa nodded again.

“Are you going to?”, he raised an eyebrow. Katsuki felt more heat rise to his face, and tried his best to keep it down.

“No”, he said again. Very firmly.

Aizawa stared at him for a pensive moment before he nodded one more time and set the notebook back down where he had found it, on the chair.

“I believe you”, he responded, to which Katsuki nodded his gratitude.

“Will you keep him from coming here?”, he asked sincerely, before he could really think about how eager to see Deku that made him sound. Aizawa sensei sighed heavily and placed both hands on his hips, pensive.

“I thought about it”, he admitted. “Both of you told me the truth, and I believe what happened was just a simple accident that will not, for both of your sakes, repeat itself. So I’m allowing him back in. But if anything goes wrong again –“

“I know”, Katsuki interrupted him, a knowing look in his eyes.

Aizawa gave him a stern look.

“I mean it”, he added. “I’m not known for giving second chances”.

Katsuki nodded.

Aizawa ran a hand across his hair and looked at the door, pensive.

“He’s outside”, he revealed.

Katsuki’s eyes widened a little at the revelation, and he couldn’t help but to tense up on the bed, damaged ears sharp with attention. He was back to wearing one of the previous versions of Hatsume’s hearing aids that Kirishima had brought for him from his dorm – she had manufactured so many of them that Katsuki had lost track of which version this one was. His hearing on the other ear was damaged, but not enough to make him completely deaf. He would probably need another hearing aid for his other ear, but Hatsume hadn’t visited yet, so he hadn’t had the chance to order one. Sensing his eagerness to see Deku, Aizawa asked:

“Do you want me to send him in?”

To which Katsuki promptly replied:

“Yes”.

Then, noticing how fast and easily his answer had come, Katsuki blinked and leaned back against his pillows, putting on a stern face.

“I mean… When you want to. No rush”, he shrugged.

If Katsuki didn’t know Aizawa sensei so well, he would have sworn he was trying to hide a smile.

“I’ll tell him to come in”, he said, walking over to the door. “Try to keep yourself together this time around, Bakugou”, he advised before he left.

And Deku came back in. The boy looked worried and guilty as he stood in front of Katsuki's bed again, getting nervous when Katsuki revealed he knew about the notebook having stayed there. He reassured Deku that he hadn't read it, and they talked a bit about how Aizawa sensei had been very strict about allowing Deku to keep visiting.

Then, they went back to that talk about One For All. Now, Katsuki was calmer and more collected – again, feeling like there was something about his medication keeping him constantly mellow about everything. He also knew better what to expect, and how to behave. He was very aware of the fact that, if anything, no matter how small, went wrong, he would be kept from seeing Deku again for a long, long time, and he didn't want that. So he put a special effort into not freaking out and not breaking any more bones, even though the conversation set him on the edge.

Deku told him that, not only Katsuki had One For All forever, but Deku himself had Katsuki's quirk as well. He asked him how he felt about that, but Katsuki couldn't tell – he needed time to think and properly process his emotions regarding that. It wasn't an easy revelation to deal with, and he couldn't afford to lose his cool while Deku was in the room, under the risk of getting the nerd banned. So he opened a little door in his head that said "To be dealt with later" and stored the knowledge that Deku had his explosion quirk in there.

He wasn't particularly happy with the situation. He hadn't been particularly happy with the fact that he had One For All, and now there was this. Deku, with his quirk. That had to be his child version's worst nightmare coming to life – Deku, the quirkless loser who despite that insisted on playing heroes, getting a quirk like his one. Katsuki had always taken a great pride on his quirk, from a very early age. It was a special combination of his parents own quirks, and no one else had anything slightly similar to that. Its signature was so especially and specifically *his*, and no one else's, and that was what made it even more incredible than it already was.

But now, it wasn't just his anymore. It was Deku's as well.

And yeah, Katsuki hadn't come out of this empty handed – he had gotten Deku's quirk in return –, but he had never asked for that. He never meant to keep One For All. He wished he could pass it completely back to Deku, if only Deku would find a way to return him his quirk completely too.

But he knew that wasn't possible. And for that, he would have to find a way to come to terms with this – to live with this. Maybe if they made a promise to never use each other's quirks. Katsuki knew he would never want to use One For All again, because he didn't need that borrowed power and he could fare for himself pretty well with just his quirk, thank you. And Deku had a lot of other quirks stored within One For All too – he didn't have to use Katsuki's specifically. So yeah. There was that.

They started playing that stupid game of "truth or lie" that Deku suggested they'd do, and that Katsuki only agreed to participate in because he was tired of having so many arguments over so many small things. So he indulged in Deku's preposition and responded to his questions sincerely, even if most of them sounded meaningless at the beginning. Then, they started to get more serious, until Deku finally approached the incident at Katsuki's birthday party and the argument in the deposit room of the museum. Those had been turning points for

them, he knew that, and talking about those subjects again brought back a lot of emotions Katsuki still had a hard time processing.

But he felt calm. He felt easy. There must be something pretty good in those pain medicines Recovery Girl was pumping him with, because he didn't feel like exploding Deku's face or telling him to go to hell. Instead, he responded sincerely: *You want me to apologize, right?*

Because yeah. Deku liked apologies. And Katsuki had fucked up in the past, he wasn't beyond admitting that. He also had apologized already in the past, but that didn't mean he hadn't fucked up again after that. If Deku wanted his apology – for calling him quirkless, and for acting like he was deadweight – then Katsuki would do it. Because yes, he admitted it, he liked the nerd, and he cared for him, and he wanted them to be ok again. He wanted them to be… to be…

He couldn't put it into words, not just yet. But he wanted them to be ok. He wanted Deku to be close to him again. Those six months where they didn't talk, after the incident from his birthday, had been awful, to put it lightly. Katsuki had grown and become mature enough to admit it: he had missed Deku. And he had worried about him. Constantly.

So yeah. If he needed to apologize, no matter how much he hated that idea, he would do it. He would do anything to have Deku back in his life.

He wasn't sure when that sentiment had started. But he was too smart, too intelligent, to deny the evidence in front of his eyes: he felt happier when Deku visited. He felt happier when the nerd was there with him, talking to him, laughing at his teasing remarks, calling him Kacchan and all that shit he did with his dimples. He felt at peace. When Deku was there with him, there was nowhere else he'd rather be.

Which was why he was surprised when Deku cut his visit short. He claimed they had already talked about enough subjects for the day – which didn't make sense, because they had discussed two topics at most – and that he would be leaving. Katsuki didn't want him to leave, so he tried to tease him into staying, but even that wasn't enough. And so he watched Deku leave, his eyes flooding with fondness as he watched the door close behind his friend.

Not too long after Deku left, and right after Katsuki finished eating – with the mortifying help of one of UA's nurses – he received an unexpected visit.

Well, not too unexpected. The thing is: he had been dozing off because of the medication, the TV turned on in some random movie channel, when an unforeseeable flash of pink erupted in front of his half-lidded eyes. He blinked a few times to make sure he wasn't hallucinating before he made sense that there was a person there, in the room with him, standing directly in front of his bed.

"Hatsume?", Katsuki asked, blinking away the fogginess that always appeared in his brain moments before he fell asleep and trying to prop himself up into a more sitting position. To his surprise, Hatsume had her arm held on a sling, and with her free hand she was holding a tiny white paper box.

"Hi", she greeted, a lot more quietly than Katsuki was used to seeing her.

There was something different about her – maybe it was because this was the first time Katsuki was seeing her outside the context of her Officine. Her face and arms were clean, as if she had showered recently, and though she was wearing her regular working clothes, they seemed clean too. Katsuki frowned at her and what seemed to be her hesitant appearance – she wasn't meeting his eyes and her head was downcast. She was almost bowing at him.

"I thought Recovery Girl would have fixed your arm already", he commented, because he didn't really know what to tell her when she was behaving like this. He knew how to react to her chaotic energy, but this shy, wary stance was something new to him.

"She wanted to", Hatsume admitted, shifting her weight from one foot to the other. "But I told her no".

That made Katsuki frown.

"Why not?", he questioned. If he remembered it correctly, he had been the one behind her injury – he had thrown her out of the building with such strength that her shoulder popped out of place. This was her first time visiting him, which meant she'd been stuck with a useless arm for around two weeks, now. He couldn't imagine how much she was being set back at her work because of that, and he couldn't find any reason for her not to want it to be healed.

Hatsume rubbed a hand on her nose and continued not to look at Katsuki. She looked at his feet instead as she spoke.

"I didn't feel like it would be fair", she shrugged. Her shoulders were hunched forwards, as if she was carrying a heavy weight over them. "I mean, if I hadn't gone back inside the building, you… You wouldn't have…"

Oh. Katsuki understood it, now.

"You don't have to punish yourself because of this", Katsuki said, feeling angry that his own failure at escaping was causing someone else such pain. "You can ask her to heal you, I don't care".

“But I do”, Hatsume pointed out. “I shouldn’t have gone back in there. I should have waited outside with everybody else. But you seemed like you had the situation under control, and I had spent so much effort into that stupid baby… I barely even registered what was going on until I was at the hospital. And when they told me what happened… When they told me that you got stuck behind because you prioritized my rescue…”, she lowered her head further, voice becoming tight. Katsuki couldn’t tell if she was crying because her pink hair was covering most of her face, but she sounded like she wanted to.

He immediately hated this situation. He was good at combat, at winning, and at screaming. He wasn’t good at comforting people – he had never been. Even if he could understand where all her emotion was coming from, he wasn’t the type of person to say “there, there” or to tap her gently on the back – even if he wanted to, he couldn’t, given the state of his hands and arms. So instead, he did the next best thing.

“Stop being an idiot and go tell Recovery Girl to fix your shoulder”, he commanded. “I don’t want to have you martyrizing yourself on my account”.

Hatsume cracked a smile at this, rubbing her cheeks and her nose with the back of her hand.

“I wanted to tell you I’m sorry”, she continued.

“Sorry for *what*?”, Katsuki scoffed. “You couldn’t have predicted that there were more bombs up there, or that the villains would find a way to make them blow up even though they were tied up. I don’t blame you, so you shouldn’t, either”.

Hatsume finally lifted her head and looked at Katsuki’s face. Her yellow eyes were wet, and her face was scrunched up as if she was holding back tears.

“You almost died because I went back there”, Hatsume pointed out.

“But I didn’t”, Katsuki shrugged.

“You’ve been hospitalized for basically two weeks. There’s no prediction of when you’ll be discharged. And you’ll need therapy –“

“I already went to therapy before”, Katsuki pointed out.

“I mean physical therapy, and yes, regular therapy, and… And…”, she shook her head, lowering it again. “Look”, she said. “I’m in the support department. I’m not used to this sort of… thing you people at the hero department do. The only injuries I’ve dealt with are work related, and ok, I get that you’ll probably get your stomach pierced a few more times in the future when you become a pro, but all I’m trying to say is…”, she sighed.

Katsuki kept staring at her.

She walked around the bed and handed him the white box.

“I made this for you. As a proper apology”, she explained. “And I know you don’t care, but I really am sorry”.

Katsuki stared at her. He stared at his casted arms, and then back at her face.

“I don’t know if you’re trying to humiliate me or something, but in case you can’t tell, my hands are kind of inoperative right now”, he pointed out, giving her a look. He was feeling weirdly calm, all things considered.

She blushed intensely and rubbed a hand at her face, retrieving her hand and opening the box herself.

“Sorry”, she said again, and Katsuki found that he didn’t really like the way she kept apologizing to him.

It didn’t suit her personality, he supposed. He preferred the workaholic Hatsume, who did her best and worked very hard to be the best at what she did. That was a behavior Katsuki could admire.

“Here”, she said. “It’s a new hearing aid. The best one so far”, she explained.

“I was meaning to talk to you about that”, Katsuki said. “I still haven’t gone through the exam –“

“You won’t need the exam”, Hatsume clarified. “I took the liberty to ask Recovery Girl for some data, nothing sensitive, so you don’t have to worry about it, but that was enough to let me project the perfect aid for your ears. Yes, both of them, she told me about your partial hearing loss”, she added before Katsuki could say anything. “So what do you say? Can I put them on you?”

Katsuki found himself weirdly glad that she had asked for his permission instead of going ahead and touching him, like Recovery Girl and the nurses of UA tended to do. He nodded at her, so Hatsume set the little box down and leaned forward, carefully and skillfully removing the hearing aid Katsuki was wearing. She placed it near the box on the bed and retrieved the new ones. Katsuki immediately spotted the difference – his old ones were black, whereas the new ones matched his skin tone perfectly.

“Other than the color, the material is different too”, Hatsume said. Her breasts were rubbing against Katsuki’s face as she leaned over him to put the new aids on, but he found himself weirdly unaffected by that. “It’s revested with a synthetic rubber-like league that will adapt to your skin’s color, temperature, and texture. Basically no one will be able to tell you’re wearing an aid. And also”, she continued, moving on to his other ear. “I’ve made it around 15 times more resistant than the last version I gave you, which means that not even an explosion will break it. I’ve adapted the loud-noise filter so that it won’t cause you feedback when you use your quirk, and it has a biometric identifier so that only you can turn it on or off. I’ll have to borrow your hand for a sec”, she added, carefully grabbing one of Katsuki’s casted arms and moving it towards his right ear.

“Ouch, ouch –“, he protested. For some reason, he didn’t feel embarrassed to show pain in front of her – her job was basically to find ways around his weaknesses. She pressed the tip of Katsuki’s pointing finger against the hearing aid for a few seconds, and then she gently led his arm back into resting beside his body.

“Ok, now the other”, she announced, before doing the same to his other hand and his other ear. Once she was done, she stood back, hands on her hips and a satisfied look on her face. “There. Now you can turn it on and off just by touching it. But – since your arms will be out of commission for a little while –“, she continued, “I took the liberty to add a voice command to it as well. Override code 285/E/H-A. Owner voice register: now”.

Katsuki stared at her. She smiled and nodded at him, mouthing the words: *say your name*.

“Bakugou Katsuki”, Katsuki said loudly. The hearing aid made a pinging sound, and Hatsume raised her thumbs at him.

“Now you can just tell it to shut down or turn on, and it will. Also, they’re very ergonomic, so you can wear them on your sleep and throughout the entire day and they won’t hurt you. I added a special battery to it that lasts four times longer than the regular one”, she pointed out. “I know you said you’ll have to make some exams, so come back to me if you need to adjust them after you do”.

Katsuki nodded. It didn’t feel like he was wearing aids at all, and now he could hear a bunch of things – the TV humming low in the background, the birds chirping outside, some low conversation a few rooms away. He looked up at Hatsume and offered her a smirk.

“Thanks for that”, he said sincerely, without even having the heart to feel embarrassed of showing gratitude. He really was thankful for all the effort she put into making the perfect hearing aid for him. He doubted anyone else in Japan had better aids than he did.

“Don’t mention it”, Hatsume said. “It was the least I could do, after you literally almost died to save me”.

Katsuki huffed out a breath.

“You’re not getting rid of me that easily”, he jested.

She mustered a small smile.

“I’ll… put your old aids in the box in case you ever need a spare one”, she announced, closing the box up and placing it on the tiny nightstand beside his bed. “But the ones I gave you are so good you shouldn’t need spare ones”, she shrugged.

Katsuki nodded.

“I was serious about your shoulder”, Katsuki said, a bit more sober. “Go talk to Recovery Girl. Tell her to finish healing it. You don’t have to punish yourself over what happened”.

Hatsume’s smile vanished, and she looked away in embarrassment.

“I… I don’t really…”

“It makes me feel like a loser, seeing you like this”, Katsuki added with sincerity. “I didn’t mean to pop your shoulder out of place, so if you really want to show me how sorry you are,

go to her and fix it. Think of all the things you could be doing to help other people but aren't because of your injury".

Hatsume opened and closed her mouth, trying to search for arguments to use. Katsuki hated when people did this, but he said nothing.

"… Ok", she submitted eventually. She pointed Katsuki with a serious nod. "I'll go to her and have it fixed".

"Good", Katsuki nodded.

"I should get going now", she said, back at not meeting his eyes. "So… thanks again".

Katsuki huffed out an unamused breath.

"You're welcome".

Hatsume turned on her heels and left the room, leaving Katsuki alone.

He was feeling tired and sleepy, like he always did after eating. They had just started giving him solid foods again, which was apparently demanding more energy from his organism to digest it. He wished his stupid body would just go back to normal already instead of struggling to do something as basic as digestion, but apparently, he didn't have such luck.

He stared at the TV in front of his bed. The movie had ended and now there was a news show on, but they weren't talking about anything relevant. Katsuki supposed that, if they were allowing him to watch the news channel now, that must be because the media finally stopped talking about the museum and about what happened to him. He didn't know much about how the media coverage went, but he could guess it was a shitshow as usual.

"Turn hearing aid off", Katsuki said out loud, blinking in wait for a response. There was a shy pinging at his ears, before one of his ears became muffled and the other became barely functional. The humming of the TV was reduced into a faraway buzz that Katsuki could barely make sense of, and so he closed his eyes and allowed himself to fall asleep before someone else arrived to visit.

He waited eagerly for Deku's arrival.

If someone had asked him about it, he would have denied it, but Deku's little visits were the best part of his day. Katsuki couldn't really name the feeling, but seeing the nerd there, willing to talk to him and keep him company after ignoring him for six whole months was something that made Katsuki's heart beat a little bit faster.

Which was why he was a little bit disappointed when Deku arrived with only a phantom shadow of his usually warm smile, and barely even met his eyes while they spoke about nothing. He had his notebook with him, and he was clinging to it as tightly as he had done on the first day, which told Katsuki that today's heart-to-heart was going to be a bit more intense than the previous one. He couldn't imagine what could be worse that "we have each other's quirk now", so Deku's behavior was kind of keeping him on the edge.

"You're being weird", Katsuki accused once Deku stopped talking and a weird silence fell between them.

"What?! Why?!", Deku asked, sounding exasperated and surprised. Katsuki huffed.

"I don't know. But you're acting weird", he accused again.

Deku tilted his head and gave him a look.

"Kacchan, I just got here. How can I be acting weird?", he questioned.

"I don't know", Katsuki said, frustrated. "But there's something off about you, I just don't know what it is", he shrugged helplessly. He just wanted Deku to go back to acting warmly towards him, and, upon this realization, he immediately felt embarrassed by that desire.

"I – maybe it's because I ate something weird at breakfast this morning –", Deku tried to bullshit him.

"You suck at lying, too", Katsuki interrupted.

Deku sighed in defeat.

"*Fine*. But I don't know why you think I'm being weird", he said, helpless.

Katsuki rolled his eyes with impatience. If Deku wasn't going to be honest with him, Katsuki wasn't about to be honest, either.

"Whatever, nerd".

A pause.

"Now you're the one being weird", Deku had the audacity to accuse.

Katsuki glared at him.

"Shut up", he said, his tone lighter than usual.

There was a pause, comfortable. Deku averted his eyes away, and Katsuki found that he couldn't keep his eyes off the notebook in Deku's grip – the object that hid away so many of Deku's thoughts, of Deku's secrets.

"So", Katsuki broke the silence between them. "What've you got for me today?", he nodded at the notebook.

Deku blinked, and a blush found its way to his face, making his freckles disappear.

"Oh. Well, uh. I, um, I wanted to talk a bit about how I feel. Felt. Um".

Katsuki narrowed his eyes. His heart started to beat a bit faster, but he ignored it.

"So that's why you're being weird, then", he pointed out.

Deku's eyes widened.

"No! There's nothing to be weird about!", he tried to defend himself. "I just think it's important that you know how everything that happened affected me so we can understand how it affected you and try to find a way to –"

"Deku", Katsuki interrupted him.

"Y-Yes?"

"I'm messing with you again", Katsuki scoffed, trying to make the boy feel more comfortable and at ease. "Learn to read the room", he added as a jest.

"O-Oh", Deku blinked, blushing harder. "Right. Ok".

Awkward silence. Katsuki waited with a bit of impatience, and when Deku didn't say anything, he rolled his eyes and added:

"Whenever you're ready, nerd".

"O-Ok", Deku said, head lowered. He looked uncertain, but determined. There was a small pause, until he continued: "Look –"

A knock on the door.

"Hello, Bakugou-kun", a nurse's head popped into the room. "Recovery Girl is here to see you. Can she come in?"

She always comes in without asking first, what the fuck is this about?, Katsuki thought. He exchanged one glance with Deku, trying to read his face.

Before he could provide the nurse with an answer, the door was pushed open and the small figure of Recovery Girl stepped inside – despite Kacchan's lack of confirmation. *That's more like it.*

“Midoriya-kun”, she greeted, seeming slightly surprised. “Fancy seeing you here”.

“Recovery Girl!”, Deku greeted. “H-Hi. Nice to see you”.

“I can tell you the same, my boy. As for you”, she pointed her cane at Kacchan, stepping closer to him. “How have you been behaving?”, she asked like the grumpy old hag Katsuki knew she was.

“I didn’t do anything”, Katsuki provided grumpily, which didn’t earn him any points.

“Good. You *shouldn’t* be doing anything”, Recovery Girl pointed out.

The nurse who had announced her entrance was following her closely, and then she placed a step beside the bed so that Recovery Girl could hop on. She inspected Katsuki’s casted arms.

“You made a number on this one”, she commented after a while, gesturing at Katsuki’s rebroken hand. “The other one can be cleared today, but this one will need to stay in the cast”.

“For how long?”, Katsuki asked, sounding angrily disappointed.

“Long enough for it to heal on its own”, Recovery Girl told him sharply. “Aizawa told me that you did it on purpose, so take this as a lesson to be learned”.

Katsuki sighed, rolling his eyes with impatience.

“I didn’t do it on *purpose*, I was trying to check if my quirk was still here!”, he protested, angry.

“Why wouldn’t it still be here?”, Recovery Girl asked, suspicious.

Katsuki’s lips formed a thin, displeased line. He hesitated for a second too long. He didn’t know how much Recovery Girl knew about One For All, even if she had been there when Katsuki ate Deku’s hair all those months ago. He was better off not risking revealing too much about what he knew.

“I wanted to check if I could still use it”, he corrected himself. “That’s what I meant”.

“I see”, Recovery Girl said, removing the cast from Katsuki’s good arm, “but there were better ways of doing that. You were reckless, so your arm stays in this cast until your hand is doing better. It needs more time to heal”.

Katsuki sighed again, displeased by these news.

“Come on –“

“I’ll see what I can do in a couple of weeks”, she interrupted his incoming tantrum.

“A couple of *weeks*?!”, Katsuki questioned, indignant.

“Yes, and that’s the best you’re going to get. Now sit still, will you”, she announced right before leaning in and giving him a peck on the cheek.

Katsuki made a disgusted face, but didn’t lean away from Recovery Girl. Her quirk soon enough made an effect, because he flexed and unflexed his now good hand with ease.

She hopped off the little step and nodded at the nurse, who stepped in to check on the free arm. Once they assessed Katsuki was as well as he could be, Recovery Girl placed both hands on the top of her cane.

“Keep behaving, trouble boy”, she advised, turning to look at Deku. “And you, keep an eye on him”.

“*H-Hai*”, Deku nodded. He had stepped away from the bed in order to give the healing hero space to work, but now he was back at Katsuki’s side, anxiously avoiding to look at him.

“You’re seeming more aware today, Bakugou”, she commented. “Maybe you’ll be out of here before your arm is out of that cast”.

That made a light shine in Katsuki’s horizon. He couldn’t wait to be out of this place and back into his room, where he could relax in peace without being constantly drugged and constantly examined.

“I’ll hold you on that”, he responded grumpily, even though he was secretly glad.

“And since you’ve been acting properly to my staff, I have good news for you”, she continued. “I’m allowing you to get your phone back”.

Katsuki’s eyebrows shot up at this. His day was starting to get much, much better.

“Finally”, he groaned in relief. He kept flexing his good hand, as if to make sure it would stay functional.

“But – if you overwork yourself, I’m taking it back right away, do you understand?”, Recovery Girl threatened with a raised eyebrow, the words being said in a motherly tone.

“Yes”, Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“Yes…?”, Recovery Girl questioned.

“Yes, *ma’am*”, he added, sounding like the words tasted bitter on his tongue.

“Good”, she nodded. “Your mom will bring it to you later today. I already talked to her. You can use it to study and to distract yourself while you’re still here”.

“Ok”.

“Call me if you need anything. I’ll leave you two alone, now”, she announced, turning her back on them and heading towards the door.

Deku looked at Katsuki, waiting for him to thank the old lady for her service. Instead, he used his now free hand to sign: *old hag,* with a shit-eating grin stamped on his face.

Deku offered him a disapproving look before shouting after her:

“T-Thank you, Recovery Girl!”

The old lady merely waved her hand and walked out the door, the nurse closing it behind them.

“Well”, Katsuki was the one who broke the silence, turning back to Deku with a pleased look on his relaxed face. “At least I’ve got one arm back. I was *so* done having people do everything for me”.

Deku turned to him again, and Katsuki noticed the way his eyes became softer.

“You were having a hard time accepting that, weren’t you?”, he asked sympathetically.

“Tell me about it”, Katsuki rolled his eyes. “I couldn’t even grab some water without feeling like a helpless baby”, he admitted.

Truly, being fed and watered by other people was starting to drive him insane. He supposed the only reason why he didn’t have a full-blown breakdown yet was because of the meds. They kept him calmer than usual, and sedated, he supposed. Like a feral animal in a zoo cage.

“You were severely injured, Kacchan. It’s only natural –“, Deku tried to reason.

“Ah, spare me”, Katsuki interrupted him. “I don’t need your little motivational speech”, he said, but his tone was lighter than the semantics of his words. He was, overall, in a pretty good mood.

There was a pause. Deku said nothing, and Katsuki had one free arm, his phone, and a glimpse of a release date. He was in such a good mood that he ended up closing his eyes without realizing, dozing off in the comfortability of Deku’s reassuring presence beside him.

“I was terrified, you know”, Deku said eventually. Katsuki, half-asleep already, tilted his head towards him with his eyes still closed.

“Hm?”, he questioned, only paying half attention.

“When I found you. I was terrified”, Deku admitted.

Silence. Katsuki reopened his eyes, a bit more aware now. There was a grim look on Deku’s face, but he wasn’t looking at Katsuki. He was staring at the floor. Katsuki was suddenly reminded of Deku’s weird behavior from previously, and mentally kicked himself for forgetting about it. He had been so caught up in his own good news that he completely forgot that Deku probably bore bad ones.

“Well, actually, as soon as I heard you were still inside the building, I got terrified”, Deku continued, avoiding his eyes. “But when I found you – I don’t think I can even describe the

feeling".

Katsuki stared at him in silence. Allowing him to speak, allowing him to continue.

"I think I understood you a little bit better, back then. Why you were so upset –", he hesitated, swallowing dry. "Why you were so… shaken by watching me die. I could barely go through watching *you* die. And I don't want to repeat that ever again. I can't imagine what it would be like, going through that twice like you did".

Silence.

"So yeah, I understand why you called me quirkless. Even though I don't agree with what you did", he concluded.

Katsuki sighed. This again? He thought he had already solved this issue. He didn't want to keep chasing his own tail like a stupid dog; he didn't want to keep having the same arguments as if they were stuck in a broken record.

"I already told you –", he started, but Deku didn't let him finish.

"You're sorry, I know", he said. "And I'm sorry too".

A pause. Katsuki watched Deku with attentive eyes.

"That's why I wanted to talk about feelings today", Deku concluded, finally looking at him.

Katsuki huffed out a breath.

"Yeah, I'm waiting on that", he admitted, trying to sound serious while at the same time not pressuring Deku into speaking.

"I think I get your point, now. During all those arguments, all those discussions. You were just trying to preserve yourself", Deku said with a soft smile.

Katsuki's brain halted. What the fuck?

"Preserve myself?", he asked, frowning in confusion. What the hell was Deku going on about?

"Sure, you were trying to protect me too, but mostly –", Deku shrugged. "You were trying to protect yourself. From feeling the pain of… watching something like that again".

Silence.

Katsuki thought about it – he really thought about it. At first, Deku's statement offended him, because he hadn't gone through all that shit, all that effort, to have Deku say he only did it because he was thinking about himself. But thinking back to their relationship, from its very start… Katsuki had really been preserving himself.

Deku scared him, so what did he do? He pushed him away. He ignored him. He called him names when he bothered him too much, but overall, he just pretended he didn't exist. That had been his first act of preservation towards himself – he didn't really *get* Deku, and Deku made him feel insecure, so he shut him out of his personal bubble where he was amazing and incredible. Because Deku – Deku praised him, and Deku *loved* him, but he also acted like Katsuki was a breakable little thing, as if he needed help, and more than that – a quirkless person's help. Deku was the epitome of all of Katsuki's insecurities and uncertainties about himself, so pushing him away was the only way Katsuki found to preserve his ego.

But had he done everything else to protect himself? Had he called Deku quirkless and told him to stay back and told him not to get involved with the shit back at the museum because he didn't want to get hurt? No, he didn't think so. He had done those things for Deku's sake, because now, after all that shit that they went through, he cared for him more than he knew how to put into words.

But now that Deku laid this possibility out for him – now that he raised this question in Katsuki's mind – he couldn't help but to wonder if the nerd was right. Maybe he had a point. Maybe Katsuki *had* been thinking about sparing himself the pain of seeing Deku suffer, because he cared too much about him to stand seeing him injured or dying again. The thought of losing him made his heart break. The thought of never seeing him again sent him into the brink of madness. Was he so wrong for not wanting to see a loved one suffer?

"Am I wrong?", Deku questioned upon Katsuki's silence. Katsuki turned back to him, pensive.

"No", he ended up admitting. "But I wasn't thinking about myself back then", he clarified, because he didn't like the thought of Deku assuming he only did what he did for his own sake. "I was just thinking about you, and keeping you safe".

Deku looked away, looking equally pensive. He looked confused, and there was the hint of a nervous smile appearing on his stern lips.

"So you do care", he said, and Katsuki wanted to use his newly free hand to pull at his hair and scream. Really? This again?

"How many times am I going to have to say it?", he snapped.

Silence.

Then, looking at Deku's face – at Deku's eyes – a realization dawned upon Katsuki.

"You don't believe me", he accused, a sense of desperate frustration sitting heavy at his chest.

How much more would he have to do, what else would have to say, to make Deku believe it when he told him he cared? Had his harsh words – *take a swan dive off the roof of the building!* – had been so unforgivable that Deku would be forever scarred by them? Had his behavior, his treatment, his childish insecurity been so monstrous, so permanent, that Deku would never believe in what now lied in Katsuki's heart?

“I do! I do, now”, Deku tried to say, but Katsuki’s chest was already constricted.

“You sure don’t sound like it, Deku”, he said, ending up sounding a little disappointed.

“I do believe you! it’s just – It’s hard, for me”, Deku admitted, sounding a little bit desperate.

Katsuki frowned at him.

“What is?”

“Having to go through that all over again, inside my head. Having to go through…”, he trailed off.

Katsuki watched him with increasingly hard patience, desperate to *understand*.

“Through what?”, he urged.

Deku bit his lower lip.

“Kacchan, there’s something I need to tell you”, he said in a decisive tone, and if Katsuki had thought shit was getting real before, it was because he didn’t know what was about to happen now. Deku turned to meet his eyes again, and they were serious, and sad, and a little bit afraid.

“Well, go the hell ahead”, Katsuki retorted, trying to sound sure of himself. He was in a hurry to know, to understand. He was in a hurry to make sense of Deku’s constant difficulty in believing in him.

Deku lowered his eyes. As if he couldn’t quite face Katsuki when he said what he needed to say.

“I – I was connected to the villain”.

Katsuki blinked at him. Maybe it was the medication making him slow, but he didn’t quite follow Deku’s train of thought.

“What villain?”, he asked.

Deku spared him a glimpse before averting his eyes again, incapable of facing him.

“The one in the sewer. I was bound to him, just like I was bound to you for a month. I could feel what he felt”.

Katsuki processed that. So Deku had been bound for the villain for a bit, what was the big deal? Katsuki supposed that was what happened when Deku disappeared in front of his eyes, the villain had taken him back, which was the expected outcome of his quirk. But Deku was telling him that he could feel what the man felt…

And Katsuki had blown the fucker to near-death.

His eyes became wide with realization.

I could feel what he felt.

“I know it wasn’t your fault”, Deku added before Katsuki had the chance to say anything, sounding empathetic and reasonable and understanding. None of the things Katsuki deserved right now. “And I don’t blame you, not in the slightest. I just think you should know”, he said.

Silence. Tenser, this time. Katsuki took his time to process what he was being told, to process the now pretty obvious fact that, by almost killing the villain, he had almost killed Deku along with him. He had been so desperate to stop the man and to make him pay for stealing Deku from him that he hadn’t thought, he hadn’t predicted that his actions would doom Deku too. All the happiness brought to him by Recovery Girl’s good news were thrown out the window in the face of Deku’s revelation, because Katsuki didn’t deserve to be happy after what he did to Deku.

Now his shyness and his seemingly off stance made sense. He knew what Katsuki would feel upon this learned truth. He knew what Katsuki would think.

“How long?”, Katsuki questioned. Now he was the one who couldn’t bring himself to meet Deku’s eyes.

“What?”, Deku asked, confused.

“How long were you bound to him? For how long did you… feel everything?”, Katsuki gasped, breathless. He dared to look at Deku, eyes full of terror, and Deku looked back at him, an apology written in green.

“I don’t know”, he admitted, which only made everything worse. “I honestly don’t. Minutes felt like hours, or maybe it was the other way around. But I really don’t know”.

Silence. Katsuki averted his gaze away from Deku once again, unable to meet his eyes. His good hand was tightened into a fist and his jaw was locked into a serious expression. He kept going over the events of that night, again and again, trying to think about what he could have done differently, trying to think how he could have spared Deku such pain. From what Katsuki deduced, he had spent days glued to that villain. *Days.* Stuck in such an agony that he couldn’t even tell how much time had passed, how long he’d been stuck.

Deku was silent by his side. He didn’t say anything else, but Katsuki could feel his eyes on him. Waiting for him to react. Waiting for him to say something.

He found his throat dry, and his tongue empty. There was nothing he could say to make things better.

“I think I need some rest, now”, he gasped out quietly, still not finding it in himself to look at Deku. He wanted to be alone. He *needed* to be alone. He needed to process everything, and find a way to make things better.

Could he ever make things better?

“I’ll see you tomorrow, Kacchan”, Deku said simply, complying to Katsuki’s wish with a comprehending tone and standing up from the visitor’s chair.

“Ok”, Katsuki said simply, a knot in his throat.

Deku turned around and left.

As soon as the door closed behind him, Katsuki let out a breath he hadn’t realized he’d been holding and sagged against his pillows, his eyes blurring. He took his good, shaking hand to his face and rubbed at it, then he threw his hair back and leaned back as far as he could, legs twisting and writhing on the bed and making his covers fall to the floor. The movement made his impalement injury ache, but he felt like he deserved that.

Fuck. He was such a piece of shit. All he ever did was hurt Deku, right? When they were kids, when they were in middle school, when they were in UA, when their souls were bounded, and now, more than all of those times, he had hurt him because he was an idiot. He should have fucking known that his blow would affect Deku as well, he should have fucking seen it coming from the moment he learned about the soulbond. But he hadn’t. He hadn’t, and Deku had paid the price for his stupidity.

The Howitzer was probably his strongest special attack. It was designed to fuck villains up. Katsuki had used it in the Sports Festival and it had fucked Icy Hot up. He was lucky his ice quirk had gotten in the way and protected him, otherwise…

Otherwise what? Katsuki would have killed him? For someone who constantly yelled at people to DIE!!!, Katsuki knew he wasn’t a murderer. He couldn’t be one, not if he wanted to be a hero.

Was he really so vicious? Was he really so evil? If not, then why did he keep causing Deku pain? He had come to terms with the fact that he cared about Deku, that he liked having Deku around, that he… that he… missed him. But did he deserve him? Did he deserve to be such a huge part of Deku’s life, when all he did was cause him pain and make him suffer, in such a great way and so often that Deku had a hard time believing him when he said he cared?

Katsuki would usually say he was the best of the best, but the words felt flat now. If he really was the best, he would have considered the possibility that he would hurt Deku as well. If he really was the best, he wouldn’t have condemned Deku to days of suffering, because that was the time it took the villain to return his soul, wasn’t it? Days. Days of agonizing, of suffering, of hurting, all because Katsuki acted on impulse rather than using his head, all because Katsuki was reckless and relentless and he *didn’t. think.*

What was it about Deku, anyway, that turned Katsuki into this? That made him so impulsive, so irrational, so weak? That was the core of his hatred towards him. Even as kids, Deku had made Katsuki feel weak. While everyone praised him and complimented him and counted on him to look after himself, Deku was the only one who saw him as a human, who reached out for him with a helping hand, who cared about his wellbeing and his physical state.

And before, that pissed Katsuki off – that made him defensive, because he didn't need anyone's help, let alone a quirkless kid's. But now, now Katsuki could understand that this was just Deku's nature, and what made him a good hero – he cared so much about people. He cared so much about Katsuki. And Katsuki finally, *finally*, cared about him back.

He cared enough to hate himself for what he had done. He cared enough to admit he was a weak piece of shit, and that he needed to get better. First, he had doomed All Might, then, he had almost doomed Deku… He wasn't sure if he deserved to have the boy in his life.

And that was the conclusion he reached. He didn't know if he deserved to have Deku. But it wasn't as simple as that. He couldn't simply walk out of his life, turn his back on him and be done with it. He needed to make up for his mistakes. He needed to pay for what he had done.

Katsuki usually took a power nap after Deku's daily visits, but this time, he couldn't. He was too frantic to fall asleep, he was too heartbroken to rest. There were tears pooling in his eyes and, since there was no one there to witness his weakness, weak, *weak,* he allowed himself to break down, to burst into tears and to sob brokenly while he used his good hand to clutch at his chest. He rubbed his hand at his eyes and pulled at his hair to keep himself grounded, while the other arm lied uselessly on the bed beside him. What had he done? *What had he done?*

How could Deku even stand the sight of him? How could he look at him, knowing what he had done? How could he… How could he…

"Katsuki?", a voice called from the door, and Katsuki snapped his head up to see his mom there.

She had just arrived, and his dad was behind her, and they both had very worried looks on their faces. He tried to rub his tears away before they noticed them, but he knew it was too late. They had already seen it.

"What's wrong? What happened?", Mitsuki asked in a clearly worried state, rushing to the bed and holding his shoulders. For some reason, seeing her mom so worried about him despite what he had done only made him break down harder, and he went back to a sobbing fit that only made him more embarrassed than anything. She didn't know. If she did, she would scold him. If she did, she would smack his head.

"Tell us what's wrong, son", Masaru attempted from the other side of the bed, holding Katsuki's hand and squeezing it tightly. Katsuki pulled his hand away from his father, and then he shrugged away from his mother's touch. He turned on the bed so that he was lying on his side, his back turned to his mother, and he squeezed his eyes shut so that he didn't have to look at his father.

"Leave me alone", he said, voice hoarse and constricted from all the crying. The tears only escaped his eyes faster as he forced them closed, and he pulled his bandaged knees up to his chest to lie in a fetal position.

"Go call Recovery Girl", Mitsuki instructed Masaru, and then she tried to touch Katsuki's back, but he flinched. "Katsuki, tell me what's wrong. Right now", she switched back to her

authoritative tone, which she always used when she was out of her depth.

“Leave me the *fuck* alone!”, Katsuki shouted, guttural. He grabbed his pillow with his good hand and slammed it against his mother, making her purse drop to the floor.

She didn’t explode as he had expected her to. She didn’t even call him brat. Instead, she just stood there silently, watching her son suffer without a clue what she could do.

Recovery Girl rushed into the room with a very worried Masaru, and she pushed her little step closer to the bed so that she could take a look at Katsuki at the same eye-level.

“Bakugou. Can you hear me?”, she called.

Katsuki covered his wet eyes with his wrist and the back of his hand, biting down a sob.

“I can hear you. And I want to be alone”, he said through gritted teeth, hating himself and hating his parents.

Recovery Girl nodded, even though Katsuki couldn’t see it.

“Mr. and Mrs. Bakugou, I’m afraid I must ask you to leave”, Recovery Girl said, hopping off her step and walking towards the couple. “If you could wait for me outside, please, I’ll be with you in a moment”.

“What’s wrong with him? Why is he crying?”, Mitsuki demanded, bending down to pick her purse and the pillow up.

“Is he in pain? Why is his cast off?”, Masaru added.

Recovery Girl took the pillow from Mitsuki’s hands and gestured at the door of the room.

“I believe we should discuss my patient’s state outside –“

“I want to know what’s wrong with my son! He never cries!”, Mitsuki exploded. “I’m not going anywhere until you tell me!”

Recovery Girl sighed in impatience at the Bakugou way of life.

“I believe he’s having a psychological breakdown, which is expected in his state after what he’s been through”, the old woman told them. “Discussing this in front of him will do no good to anyone, so *please,* I must insist you two wait for me outside”.

Mitsuki turned her gaze to her son, who was shaking on the bed, his eyes still closed and his good hand clutching at the hospital gown covering his chest. She yanked the pillow from Recovery Girl’s hands and bit her lower lip, before walking closer to the bed.

“I’m stepping out with your dad”, she told him gently, which was unusual for her. She carefully placed the pillow he had thrown at her beneath his head and allowed one of her hands to linger on his spiked hair for a little while. “Here, I brought your phone”, she added, fishing the device off her purse and nesting it close to Katsuki’s chest.

“Mrs. Bakugou”, Recovery Girl insisted, pointing at the door.

“We’ll come back later”, Mitsuki told him before stepping outside with Masaru. Recovery Girl closed the door behind them and walked back to Katsuki’s side, hopping on her step again and taking a good look at him.

“Are you in pain?”, she asked.

Katsuki shook his head.

“Do you want to tell me what happened?”

Katsuki shook his head again.

There was a moment of silence.

“Did Midoriya say anything to make you react like this?”

Katsuki hesitated. If he told her the truth, she would probably tell Aizawa sensei, who would probably prevent Deku from coming back.

But wouldn’t it be for the best? Katsuki didn’t deserve to see him.

But he wanted to. He wanted to so much. His silly and short visits were what got him through the day. Seeing his face was what made Katsuki stand the horrible hell that being stuck to a hospital bed with nothing to do was. Without Deku, his days in the medbay would be dull and empty and so, so boring.

Katsuki was a selfish bastard. Because he shook his head a third time.

Recovery Girl sighed.

“Are you sure you’re not lying to me?”, Recovery Girl insisted.

“I’m not lying”, Katsuki lied. “Deku had nothing to do with it”.

Recovery Girl spared him a knowing look, but she hopped off her step again.

“You seem like you’re calming down. Will you be ok while I go outside and speak to your parents?”

Katsuki nodded.

“And you’re sure you’re not in any pain? I can give you something for it”.

Katsuki hesitated. He wasn’t in any pain, but he wasn’t sure he’d be able to sleep on his own after learning what he had learned, either. And he wanted to sleep. He wanted to hide, even if for a little while, in that dark, empty refuge of unconsciousness, where he could pretend that he hadn’t hurt Deku and he could be happy with him for once.

“Give me something for it”, he requested without opening his eyes.

Recovery Girl didn't say anything, and Katsuki didn't look at her. He would have thought she had left the room and given him nothing, if it wasn't for the fact that unconsciousness claimed him just a few moments after she left.

When he woke up again, it was night time. His room was empty, and the TV was turned off.

Katsuki groaned and turned from his fetal position, so that he was lying on his back, feeling a bit sore. He didn't suppose he was ready to sleep on his side just yet, since he was still recovering from his injury. But well, he also supposed that that was a good enough punishment for what he had done.

As he moved, he sensed something hard and cold pressing against his good arm. He blinked at the object for a while before realizing it was his phone.

With a sigh, Katsuki unlocked the screen. The battery was fully charged – a courtesy from his mother. Just as he had imagined, there were several missed texts and calls from all of his friends, with messages of "get better soon!" and questions about how he was faring up. Before he replied to any of them – which he wasn't sure he'd do –, he dialed his mom's number and waited for her to pick up.

"Katsuki", her voice filtered in almost immediately. "How are you?"

Katsuki sighed.

"I'm doing better. Sorry about today", he said right away, because he knew how much he had worried her.

"Don't say sorry. It only makes me worry harder", she jested.

Katsuki huffed out a little breath of amusement.

"Did you speak to Recovery Girl?", she asked.

"No", Katsuki provided. "I just woke up, and she's not here".

"Oh. I suppose you'll see her soon", Mitsuki said. "She talked to us about your therapist".

Katsuki narrowed his eyes.

“What about her?”

Mitsuki hesitated.

“Well, you got us… very worried, today. So we thought it’s for the best if you talk to her for a bit, while you’re still in the hospital. I know the plan was to go back to therapy once you were better, but…”, she trailed off, trusting he would understand.

Katsuki sighed.

“Mom…”

“I know what you’re going to say –”, she interrupted him.

“No, you don’t”, he interrupted back. “Because I was going to say I think this is a good idea”.

There was silence in the line.

“… Really?”, Mitsuki asked, seeming surprised.

“Yeah”, Katsuki admitted with sincerity. He’d been thinking about that for a while, and after the way he reacted to Deku, he presumed he’d be better off talking to Doctor Matsuo. “I think it’d be nice to talk to her”.

Mitsuki was silent for a short while.

“Good”, she said. “That’s great, Katsuki”.

Katsuki scoffed out a laugh.

“I thought you didn’t believe in therapy”.

Rather than laughing or scolding him, Mitsuki was silent again.

“I was wrong”, she admitted eventually, serious.

Katsuki raised his eyebrows.

“That’s a first”, he commented, desperate to diffuse the tension.

“Shut up, brat”, Mitsuki scoffed. “But really, I was wrong. Therapy isn’t for weak people. And you know how I know that?”

“How?”

“Because you do it, and you’re not weak. You’re the strongest person I know”.

Katsuki stared at the ceiling with a pensive look. His mom had spent years calling him weak and telling him that he needed to be stronger. He supposed that had been her own little twisted way to make up for all the praise he received as a child. To hear her change her

rhetoric was surprising, but Katsuki didn't have the right heart to hear it in that moment. He accepted the praise, but didn't feel like he'd deserved it.

"I just called you to let you know I'm fine now", he said instead of thanking her. "So you don't have to worry about me".

Mitsuki huffed out a breath.

"I wasn't worried", she said, trying to put on a strong façade.

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

"Good night, mom".

"Good night, brat", Mitsuki told him affectionately. "And remember – you can count on us, ok? For whatever you need".

Katsuki tightened his lips. To hear his mom sound so gentle and nice was a bit alien, but it matched his feeling of disconnection from reality that his pain meds caused sometimes.

"'Kay".

His mom hung up, and Katsuki was left staring at the screen of his phone. That was the only source of light in the otherwise dark room.

He wondered what he should do for a while. He had all of his friends' messages that he could reply to, but only one person in mind who he really wanted to talk to.

He opened his chat with Deku. The last message was from six months before.

What could he possibly say, after the discovery from their previous encounter? What could he say to erase his mistake, to make it as so nothing had happened? His philosophy had always been: there's no use being stuck in the past, because you can't change what has already happened. But god, he really wished he could change it this time. He wished he could spare Deku the pain.

Now the words Deku had said when he first awoke from the coma finally made sense.

"I'm burning, Kacchan. I'm - I'm b-b-burning, please, don't burn me again, it hurts, don't - don't b-burn me –"

"I'm not burning you, Deku".

"P-Please – Agh, I – Please, Kacchan, it hurts –"

Katsuki closed his eyes, lashes heavy with guilt.

He supposed the least he could do was offer Deku an apology. That was a good place to start. He didn't know if the boy would be coming back any time soon after the way he reacted – whether it was from Deku's own reluctance after the way Katsuki reacted to him, or from a

possible prohibition from Recovery Girl because of his breakdown. Since he finally had his phone back, he decided to get that out of the way.

From: Kacchan

I'm sorry.

The reply came in less than a minute.

From: Deku

You don't have to apologize.

Katsuki sighed. Of course Deku would argue.

From: Kacchan

Yes I do.

From: Kacchan

I didn't think about you when I did what I did. I didn't think that you would be bound to that guy. The thought never even crossed my mind until you told me about it

From: Deku

Kacchan. I know

From: Deku

You have nothing to be sorry for, ok? you did what you had to do

From: Deku

I understand

Katsuki felt angry. Why was Deku so fucking forgiving about the fact that Katsuki had sentenced him to days of endless pain, when at the same time, he had stopped talking to Katsuki for smaller shit in the past? Sure, Katsuki had fucked up by calling him quirkless, but

he had done it to protect him, and Deku still had stopped talking to him for six fucking months. Half a fucking year! And now that Katsuki genuinely felt like he couldn't be forgiven, he went and forgave him. Katsuki couldn't figure Deku out for the life of him.

From: Kacchan

I'm going to make it up to you

From: Deku

You really don't have to. Please don't do anything

From: Kacchan

Deku, I can't even begin to imagine the pain you must have gone through

From: Deku

I know

From: Deku

But I understand

From: Kacchan

I want to make it up to you

From: Deku

Then recover and get your other arm healed. Deal?

From: Kacchan

No deal

From: Deku

Come on Kacchan

Katsuki huffed out an annoyed breath. He would rather have this conversation face to face, but now that he had already started this over text, he might as well continue. He didn't know when he would see Deku next, anyway.

From: Kacchan

It really disturbed me.

From: Kacchan

Knowing that you went through that, and that I didn't even know

From: Kacchan

I was just sitting there the whole time, waiting on news. While you were in there suffering because of what I did.

From: Deku

If I had known this would upset you so much I wouldn't have said anything

From: Kacchan

You would keep this from me?

From: Deku

I just don't want you to think you owe me something because you don't

From: Deku

If anything, I'm the one who owes you

From: Deku

You saved my life

From: Kacchan

And from what I'm told you saved mine

From: Kacchan

You still haven't talked about that bit much

From: Deku

I will

From: Deku

We can talk about it when I visit tomorrow

Katsuki let out a breath he didn't realize he had been holding. So Deku wouldn't stop visiting. Good.

From: Kacchan

I'll charge you on that

From: Deku

So how do you feel having one free arm?

From: Kacchan

Don't change the subject.

From: Deku

Oh, come on. Don't act like you're not glad

From: Kacchan

I am, kinda

From: Kacchan

I feel a bit more like a human person now, instead of a blob of broken limbs

From: Kacchan

I could still use my other hand, though

From: Deku

You shouldn't have broken it.

From: Kacchan

You shouldn't tell me what to do, how about that

From: Deku

I mean it, Kacchan. There were other ways we could have tested the theory

From: Kacchan

What about my quirk?

From: Deku

We shouldn't talk about this over text

From: Kacchan

Did you test it?

From: Deku

Not yet

From: Kacchan

Why the hell not

From: Deku

I want us to do it together

From: Kacchan

Bullshit

From: Kacchan

I'll be in the hospital for weeks. Aren't you the tiniest bit curious?

From: Deku

I am, but I'm not doing this alone

From: Deku

Just like you shouldn't have just gone and broken your own hand, on your own

From: Kacchan

You're really not letting this go are ya

From: Deku

No. I get worried about you, you know

Katsuki scoffed.

From: Kacchan

Welcome to my life

From: Kacchan

Now you know what it's like to constantly worry about an idiot who breaks his bones on purpose

From: Deku

Did you

From: Deku

Did you just call yourself an idiot

From: Kacchan

No I didn't shut the fuck up

From: Kacchan

If anything you're the idiot here

From: Kacchan

Now go to sleep before I break your bones

From: Deku

All right Kacchan

From: Deku

I'll see you tomorrow ^_^

Katsuki put the phone down, and its light illuminated the ceiling. He stared at it for a while, trying to figure out what he was feeling. Deku was going to visit him tomorrow, which was an improvement from Katsuki's pessimistic assumption that he wouldn't show up. Now, as long as Recovery Girl didn't block him from entering his room, Katsuki could see the nerd face to face and talk to him properly about this.

If he had to be rational, he didn't see any use in insisting on this subject. Even if it had confused the living hell out of him, Deku had already forgiven him for what happened with the Soulmonger, and apparently this was a sensitive subject. Their little conversations in the afternoons were the only joy of Katsuki's days; while he still felt like he didn't deserve Deku's forgiveness, he didn't find himself capable of giving up on them just yet. If Deku had forgiven him, then so be it. Katsuki would have to accept it, and live with it, and only ever bring it up again if the need arose. Deep down, he was aware that these texts wouldn't be the last time they ever spoke about this subject, but he also didn't want to push Deku into reliving his memories if he really didn't want to.

So, great. Deku was going to keep visiting him, and Katsuki was a step closer to getting better. Things were finally going well for them. Things were finally turning right. Katsuki still felt guiltier than he could put into words because of what had happened to Deku, but like he had said over text, he would find a way to make it up for him. He had to.

He fell asleep trying to think of grand gestures he could make to earn Deku's forgiveness, instead of being handed it.

He dreamt of soft lips and green hair.

He woke up with a jolt, eyes widening and breath catching in his throat. The dream had just happened, it had just been here, but as soon as his brain reached a conscious state again, it started to slip away from him, like sand on his hands. He tried to cling on to its details, he tried to grasp it as hard as his concentration would let him – but in the end, it was a useless effort. He had forgotten all about the dream, and now its details were gone. All he could remember was this: soft lips and green hair.

He felt kind of embarrassed about that. He could deduce where the green hair had come from, but the soft lips? How the fuck was he supposed to know what was the texture of the lips? There was only one way, but Katsuki didn't want to consider that possibility.

The thing was: Katsuki was many things, but he was not a romantic guy. From a very early age, he had decided one thing: that he wanted to be a hero. Not just any hero, but the number one hero who surpassed even All Might. And for that, he would need to have a very specific routine of training, a very controlled diet, a very tight schedule for sleeping, and absolutely no distractions. That meant no girls, and no dating. But Katsuki had never spared a second thought about girls, anyway, and he wasn't about to start that now.

They had never called his attention like they did to the other boys. Kaminari and the Grape Bastard were always ranting about girls this, girls that, and Katsuki had never seen where his friend was coming from. Hell, Hatsume had basically rubbed her breasts all over his face a couple days ago and Katsuki barely even spared a thought to that. No, girls didn't appeal to him, and he couldn't imagine himself dating one or even marrying one. Starting a family didn't really suit his style or his career – he wouldn't want to spend time raising a baby or tending for a wife when he could be fighting crime and climbing the charts.

Boys didn't appeal to him either. He had wondered about the possibility of being gay back when he was at middle school, because his lack of interest in girls caused the two extras who hung out with him to tease and mock him for a couple of days. But then, Katsuki found he didn't give a shit about boys either. They didn't turn him on just like girls didn't turn him on, and so Katsuki decided that he wouldn't force his body to have a certain reaction just because society expected him to have a boner for someone at that age. In his opinion, society could go fuck itself, and if neither boys nor girls made him feel any attraction, then he wouldn't waste his time wondering why. What he could – and would – do was to give his best to become number one; whatever came after that, he could figure out later.

So, there came his problem. Katsuki had never felt attraction for anyone. He had never had that curiosity to explore his body and the pleasures that came with it in the adolescent period – especially because his quirk involved literal *explosive hands*, which couldn't be really safe for touching oneself. And thus, he found himself very surprised and shocked to notice that, after he had the forgetful dream, he saw a little volume in the middle of his covers, coming from between his legs.

What. The fuck.

Katsuki stared at it for a moment, confused and surprised. He knew exactly what that was; what he didn't know was what it was doing there. Because green hair could only mean he had dreamt about Deku, right? And the soft lips part was still a mystery to him, but it had certainly caused a reaction. Katsuki kept staring at his half-hard erection with shocked eyes and an ashamed face, not sure how to handle himself in that situation.

"Good morning", Recovery Girl stepped into the room, and Katsuki immediately grabbed his pillow and placed it on his lap, trying his best to hide himself away from view before the old lady, of all people, saw what was going on. Recovery Girl sent him one look filled with suspicion as she saw him move, but didn't say anything as she gathered her equipment in front of Katsuki's bed. "How did you spend the night?", she asked politely, as she always did when she came to examine Katsuki in the morning.

"Ok", he said simply, swallowing dry. He raised the pillow a little bit to check if the boner had died down, and found that the volume beneath the covers had decreased exponentially. *Thank fuck.*

"Good, dear. Think you can get up to see how you're doing today?", Recovery Girl asked, her back turned to him.

Katsuki swallowed dry again and nodded, putting the pillow away. He carefully turned on his side, ignoring how his healing injury protested at the motion, and threw his legs off the bed. He then sat up slowly, carefully, and after that he stood up, testing his balance before walking. He felt a bit dizzy, but he could stand upright. Looking down, he saw his boner had mostly died down into oblivion, which he was very, *very* grateful for, even though he still had no idea why the dream about Deku and his soft lips had given him a boner in the first place.

"Come here", Recovery Girl turned to him, calling him forwards with one hand. He obeyed, walking up to her. "How's the pain?"

“It only hurts when I move too much”, Katsuki told her. “Like when turned on my side to get up. But now that I’m on my feet, it doesn’t hurt that bad”.

“I see”, she nodded, checking his heart and his lungs with her stethoscope. “It will be like that for a while. The injury was very invasive in nature, it will leave a scar. You might feel it ache a bit years from now. But with proper treatment and physical therapy, you won’t have to worry about it anytime soon”.

Katsuki nodded.

“Breathe in deep”, she commanded, and Katsuki obeyed. “Good. Any more symptoms?”

“No. I’m feeling pretty good”, he admitted sincerely.

She narrowed her eyes at him.

“You’re not saying that just to get dismissed quickly, are you, boy?”, she leaned her weight on her tiny cane.

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“As good of an idea as that is, no. I actually worry about my body enough to stay here until it’s properly healed”.

Recovery Girl huffed a breath, but didn’t disagree. Apparently, she knew enough about Katsuki to acknowledge that much was true.

“I’ll have someone bring in your breakfast in a while. We’ll try something more solid today, ok?”

Katsuki nodded. He stayed on his feet as Recovery Girl walked further into the medical bay, but, noticing this, she turned to give him a look.

“You can go back to bed, now”, she said. “Like I said, breakfast will be here soon enough”.

Katsuki nodded.

“I know. I just want to stay up for a bit. Lying down all day’s making me dizzy”.

She frowned.

“Dizzy?”

“Yeah”, Katsuki agreed. “I feel pretty light-headed sometimes”.

Recovery Girl turned to him.

“Why didn’t you tell me this before?”, she demanded.

Katsuki sighed.

“It’s not *always*. Must be because I don’t do anything all day, and my body isn’t used to lying down so much. And I only fell down one time, so I’m sure it’s nothing big”.

Recovery Girl pressed her cane down on the floor with unexpected strength.

“You *fell down*?”, she raised her eyebrows.

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“Yeah, but it wasn’t a big deal. Like I said, it’s not always –“

“You should have told me this before, boy”, she scolded, walking back towards him and pushing him into sitting on the edge of the bed. “Your head injury has healed, but it might have left sequels. Look here”, she said, shining a light on his eyes. Then, she lifted one finger in front of his face. “Follow my finger”, she instructed, moving it to the sides. Katsuki did as he was told. “Good. Now ears”, she commanded, and he turned his head to the side so that she could look into his ear. She removed his hearing aids without asking for permission. “Other”, she said, and Katsuki turned his head to the other side. “Hm. There doesn’t seem to be anything wrong with you”, she concluded, handing him back the aids. Katsuki put them on again with his good hand.

“See?”, he sighed, giving her a look. “I’m fine”.

She narrowed her eyes.

“Feeling dizzy all the time isn’t a sign of good health, young man”, Recovery Girl scolded him. “We’ll have to investigate what’s causing this. For now, eat your breakfast and –“

“Rest”, Katsuki completed for her. “I know”.

With a final attentive look, Recovery Girl left him on his own. Katsuki remained sitting down on the bed before he relented and went back to lying down, which was all he seemed to do these days.

He had always taken a good care of his health, whether it was with his diet, with his routine, with his training sessions, or with his sleep schedule. So no, as much as he absolutely hated being stuck in a hospital with only one functional arm and a couple eventual dizzy spells, he wouldn’t leave until he was cleared out. There was no pressing matter he absolutely needed to attend to, so he would just let his body heal itself and take his time with his recovery. He didn’t particularly like being seen as helpless or as weak as he felt while he was in the hospital, but he knew that he had been impaled and flatlined and almost died. He sure as fuck wasn’t risking getting dismissed too soon and ending up in a worse state than he’d been before.

Breakfast did arrive soon enough and Katsuki ate it absentmindedly. His eyes were fixed on the TV but he wasn’t paying attention to the morning show in display. Instead, his thoughts kept going back to Deku and the feeling of soft lips against his and the dreadful realization that he had dreamt about kissing someone.

That had never happened to him before. And not only that, he had dreamt about kissing Deku. *Deku.* And his body had reacted accordingly.

He wished he could remember more details about the dream. Maybe this way, he could analyze it and figure it out. This sort of thing had never happened to him before, this was the first time he ever felt anywhere close to arousal before. He felt like a stupid teenage virgin who didn't know enough about his body to figure things out.

None of Katsuki's reactions were ever out of his control; he rarely acted on impulse and all his movements were coldly calculated before he made them. The only exception to this rule, of course, was shitty Deku, who always seemed to send Katsuki's head into a mess of a frenzy and made him act before he thought about it, like it had been the case with the Soulmonger in the sewers. Plus, Deku was the first of many things of his life – first friend, first enemy, first rival –, so Katsuki shouldn't really find it so weird that the nerd had been the cause of his first boner as well.

Kirishima and Kaminari stopped by between classes to see him in the morning, and Katsuki chatted with them – or rather, listened while they chatted in front of him – for a short while before they had to leave for their second class. He didn't mention anything about the dream to them, because he was sure he would never hear the end of it if he did, but he was dying to share this with someone. It had to be someone who he trusted, someone who wouldn't mock him, and someone who wouldn't tell anyone, *ever*. Katsuki knew exactly the perfect person for the job, but he didn't really know when Doctor Matsuo would be around to talk to him.

After that, he fell asleep for his morning nap, which usually happened up until the early afternoon, which was the time Deku generally visited. Katsuki tried his best not to think about the dream as he fell asleep because he didn't want the same incident from that morning to occur again, especially not in front of Deku, of all people. So he buried his thoughts of green hair and soft lips deep inside his mind and decided to internalize that shit until he had the proper time and mental state to deal with the meaning of all that.

When he woke back up, Deku was already there, sitting patiently at the visitor's chair and silently reading the contents of his notebook while he waited for Katsuki to wake up. Katsuki found himself staring at him with curiosity, his eyes tracing his face down to his lips, which were parted. Deku was biting down on the eraser at the top of his pencil, distracted with his own annotations, and Katsuki came to the realization that Deku had always displayed a sort of oral fixation, in the sense that he was always putting things in his mouth while he thought, whether they were pencils, pens, his own fingers, or whatever was at hands.

Looking from afar, his lips didn't look soft, but they didn't look dry, either. Katsuki supposed the only way to find out for sure would be to kiss Deku, and then he wondered why the fuck he had thought about that in the first place.

"So, are you ever going to tell me how you got your quirk back?", Katsuki broke the silence, calling Deku's attention. Better stick to subjects he could make sense of.

Deku blushed and immediately tried to hide it, looking away and lowering his head.

“Are you sure you don’t remember?”, he asked instead of replying, putting his pencil away and lowering his notebook.

“Nope”, Katsuki shrugged. He really didn’t.

“Not even a tiny bit?”, Deku tried, sparing a glimpse at Katsuki. He was still blushing, as if uncomfortable talking about that, and for some childish reason, Katsuki found that irritating.

“I already told you I fucking don’t”, he said, a bit too harshly.

A pause.

“I’m – I’m sure it will come back to you”, Deku smiled instead of giving him a proper answer. Which, again, pissed Katsuki off further. That, added to the frustration caused by the dream, sent Katsuki to the edge.

“Just tell me about it already”, he demanded.

Deku sighed.

“Let’s make a deal”, he suggested, but Katsuki huffed out an impatient breath. He was tired of Deku stalling this talk, of playing Deku’s games.

“No deals”, he denied.

Deku worried at his lower lip.

“If you agree to what I had in mind for today, I’ll tell you how it went”, Deku offered.

Katsuki narrowed his eyes.

“Why are you being so mysterious about it?”, he questioned, suspicious. Really, why didn’t Deku just fill in the blanks of his memory and tell him about what had happened already? Why make such a big deal out of this?

“I’m not being mysterious!”, Deku tried to defend himself.

“Yes, you are. You got all red and blushing and shit, and now you’re trying to change the subject. What’d I do, rub my blood all over you? Because if that’s what happened that’s gross, but it’s already in the past”, he commented.

Deku closed his eyes for a moment, as if he was trying to recompose himself.

“You didn’t rub your blood on me”, he said simply.

“Then what did I do?”, Katsuki demanded. He really, really wanted to know.

“I’ll tell you about it if you tell me something”, Deku suggested.

Katsuki considered the proposition. But then he shook his head. He wasn’t playing games with Deku, especially because he felt particularly irritated with him on that day (the feeling

was, of course, completely unrelated to the fact that Deku had apparently given him his first boner ever).

“No”, he denied.

“You don’t even know what it is!”, Deku protested.

“I’m not bargaining with you. You either tell me or piss off”, Katsuki said.

Deku sighed.

“You don’t want me to tell you”, he said, almost pleadingly.

Katsuki felt even more irritation as Deku dared to *presume* what his feelings were.

“Newsflash, asshole: you don’t know what I want”, he said with an angry expression.

“Yes, but what I know is that it will come back to you –“

“Deku –“

“Kacchan –“

“If you’re not gonna tell me, then –“, he started angrily.

“Then what? Leave?”, Deku raised his eyebrows, offended. There he was, presuming shit again.

“Well, yeah!”, Katsuki spat in an impulse.

“Fine!”

“*Fine*”.

Deku got to his feet, grabbed his notebook and his pencil, and marched away. He stopped in front of the closed door of the room, silent.

“I’ll take a break before we start arguing”, he announced, as if he was leaving out of his own free will rather than because of Katsuki’s expulsion.

“Suit yourself”, Katsuki huffed simply, tilting his head away from the door and from Deku.

“In the meantime, please try to understand that there *must* be a reason why I don’t want to talk about it. I’m sure you didn’t want to talk about a lot of things when you first woke up in the hospital”, Deku said, and stepped out.

Katsuki waited until he was gone to turn and look at the closed door. Deku had barely left, and he already felt his heart ache. Katsuki didn’t know what the fuck was going on inside that fucked up head of his – he had been feeling nothing other than irritation and annoyance at Deku when the boy was there with him, but now that he was no longer there, Katsuki urged for his presence. It was like they couldn’t be apart, but couldn’t be together, either.

Fuck. His thoughts and feelings were all over the place, more than ever. He was desperate to talk to Doctor Matsuo and figure this shit out, or at least try to.

Katsuki decided to commit himself into being a little more comprehensive with Deku when the boy finally came back, which he hoped would still happen on that same day. His parting phrase made sense – Katsuki had really needed some time to himself to figure things out before he talked about them when he first woke up, so he could see where Deku was coming from.

It just… It felt so frustrating, knowing that he had done something but not remembering what it was. And this wasn't forgetting about an item on the grocery list, this was One For All. All Might's legacy and Deku's heritage and the power of generations stored into one person. This was a big deal. And Katsuki could remember nothing of it.

To his relief, Deku returned after a few minutes, looking like he had cooled off. Katsuki decided to do his best to be cool too.

"So", Deku said conversationally, but hesitantly.

"So", Katsuki replied, trying to show he was willing to speak.

Deku hesitated.

"Are you ready to talk now?", he asked.

Katsuki huffed.

"Whatever".

Deku raised an eyebrow. In return, Katsuki rolled his eyes.

"*Fine*. It's not like I can get up and run away from this conversation", he said, playing hard to get.

"As if you'd ever run away from anything", Deku commented conversationally.

"Hah. That's right", Katsuki smirked, but soon turned back to a more serious expression.

Deku stared at him for a moment, pensive.

"But what do you mean you can't get up?", he questioned, tilting his head with curiosity. He was giving Katsuki an intense look, as if trying to read him.

Katsuki looked away, embarrassed and angry. He decided to be more honest with Deku than he had been with Recovery Girl – even though he could sense that this decision would come back to bite him in the ass.

"Every time I try, I end up getting super dizzy", he said conversationally.

There was a pause.

“Kacchan”, Deku whispered, sounding horrified. “Why didn’t you tell me that?”

Katsuki scoffed.

“It’s not like I get to do any talking with your constant notebook-rambling”, he joked.

Deku’s shoulders became stiff and he looked away, clearly embarrassed. Sure, Katsuki should have predicted this: he didn’t understand the joke. He rolled his eyes with impatience.

“I’m just messing with you, for fuck’s sake”, he added.

Deku turned to him again, blushing even harder this time. He had a nervous look on his face.

“I can never tell!”, he protested, as if that was somehow Katsuki’s fault.

“I know!”, Katsuki nodded, his lips forming a thin line.

“Then why do you keep doing it?”, Deku frowned, half-offended.

“It’s not like I do it on purpose, nerd, it just – comes off like that”, Katsuki shrugged with honesty.

Deku shifted on his seat and grabbed his notebook tighter, eyes downcast for a moment before he looked at Katsuki again.

“Well, I think we need to talk about it”, he suggested.

Katsuki closed his eyes for a brief moment, trying to gather up some patience.

“Really –“

“I think we need to establish some boundaries”, Deku added, trying to be clearer.

Silence.

“About this or…?”, Katsuki trailed off.

“About several things, yeah”, Deku said, crossing his arms above his chest.

“Fine”, Katsuki agreed, realizing the conversation tone was becoming more serious.

“First. No calling me quirkless”, Deku started.

Katsuki narrowed his eyes.

“Which… you aren’t anymore”, he pointed out. Sure, he could see where Deku was coming from, since the disaster at Katsuki’s birthday party had resulted in six months of lost time between them, but there would be no point in calling Deku quirkless if he had One For All back, even if Katsuki didn’t know how or when the transfer had happened.

“I know, but in any circumstances. I want this to be our forbidden word”, Deku said with a serious tone.

Katsuki frowned.

“Forbidden word?”

“Yeah, as in, I don’t call you weak, you don’t call me quirkless. Ever”.

Katsuki scoffed.

“I ain’t weak”, he pointed out, a bit too defensively.

“Exactly”, Deku nodded.

“So you’ve got no fucking reason to call me that”, Katsuki continued.

“*Exactly*”, Deku nodded a bit more emphatically.

“But you used to be. You know, the Q-word”, he veiled his speech, mindful of Deku’s demand.

“I know”, Deku nodded. “And that will always be a part of me. And I’m not ashamed of that, Kacchan, I need you to understand that. I was born this way, and there’s nothing wrong with this. The reason I don’t want you to call me quirkless is because it reminds me of a dark period of my life – the darkest period of my life. It’s not the word itself, it’s what it represents, it’s the memories it brings back. Do you understand?”

Katsuki looked away from Deku’s pleading look. He couldn’t help but to feel a little bit guilty at that. There was a reason why the period Deku mentioned had been dark; there was a reason why he wanted to forget. The reason was Katsuki, and what he had done, and said. And he would never be able to erase that.

“Yeah”, he nodded, not meeting Deku’s eyes.

“Good”, Deku nodded back. “Second point: we’re friends now”.

Katsuki met his eyes again, trying to read what was hidden in green.

“Ok”, he said a bit hesitantly.

“That’s not just something I’m saying. It’s something that we both agree on, right?”, Deku asked, sounding like he genuinely didn’t know the answer. “Because it’s ok if you don’t want to be friends-friends, it’s ok if you want to settle with colleagues or acquaintances or –“

Katsuki couldn’t help but to huff out an incredulous breath. Deku had given him a fucking boner and he wanted them to be *acquaintances*? It was obvious to Katsuki, even if he was still very confused about his own emotions, that he and Deku were more than that. They were past the acquaintance state, by a longshot.

“Deku”, he interrupted the boy’s rant.

“W-What?”, Deku asked, embarrassed.

Katsuki gave him a look.

“We’re *friends*. Colleagues and acquaintances don’t almost die for each other, especially more than once”, he pointed out.

Deku paused for a moment

“Oh”, he settled for saying.

“Yeah”, Katsuki nodded his head, lips thin again.

Deku swallowed dry and turned back to his notebook, rubbing one of his eyes idly as he read his annotations.

“Ok. So, um, as friends, we can banter and all that. It’s all ok, as long as you don’t call me the Q-word”, he resumed, eyes on the notebook.

“Ok”, Katsuki agreed. He had no reason not to.

“And – I don’t know”, Deku added, a blush rising to his face again. “Maybe we can hang out more”.

Katsuki raised his eyebrows at the proposition, surprised not only by it but also by the phrasing.

“This is way cheesier than you pictured in your head, you know”, he teased.

Deku became even redder on the face, his freckles disappearing. He looked everywhere but at Katsuki’s general direction, and if Katsuki was seeing it right, he could spot sweat blooming on Deku’s brow.

“I – I-I –“, he stuttered helplessly, lost.

“Deku”, Katsuki called, stern.

“Yes”, Deku swallowed dry.

“You don’t have to control it”, Katsuki pointed out.

Deku finally looked at him again, blinking in confusion.

“What?”

“*Friendship*, dickhead”, Katsuki clarified. “You don’t control it. You just go through it. Stop trying to take control, because I really can’t stand being ordered around”, he said as gently as he could.

Deku continued to blink, and he squinted a bit as he read the meaning behind Katsuki's words.

"Oh, right, ok –"

"We're friends now and that's it", Katsuki added firmly. "We don't need a hanging out schedule".

Deku worried at his lower lip, acknowledging Katsuki's point.

"Right", he said, opening his notebook and erasing something with the eraser on the top of his pencil. "So, ok, we're friends".

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

"Yeah. Are you gonna make a shirt that says it?", he teased.

Deku hesitated.

"N-No?", he said, blushing.

Katsuki stared at him with humor in his eyes.

"You don't sound so sure there", he teased further.

"No, I won't make a shirt", Deku said a bit more confidently, now erasing more things from his notebook. *Did he actually fucking write something about making a shirt in there?,* Katsuki asked himself. "But since we're friends, why didn't you tell me about getting dizzy?", Deku questioned, which made Katsuki frown.

"I don't know", he shrugged. "It's not something that pops up in regular conversations".

If he had to be honest, the real reason was: he didn't want to sound weak. That had always been his Achilles' heel, and old habits die hard. He might have grown into a better person, now, and yes, his short-lived hubris at the sewers and his constant arguing with an amnesiac Deku might have taught him a bit about humility, but he was still a person who was very worried about his pride and his image – despite his constant claims of not caring about what anyone thought. Recovery Girl needed to know about his dizziness because she was the person in charge for his health and recovery; Deku, on the other hand, had no reason to know, but Katsuki had just told him anyway. That was what friends did, right? Shared information with each other?

"But you should have said something!", Deku continued to protest. "Have you talked to Recovery Girl and Aizawa sensei –"

"Yes", Katsuki cut him short. "And they have all reached the same conclusion that this is something related to my head injury, yadda yadda yadda. Can you stop worrying so much now?"

Deku blinked at him.

“Third point – worrying”, he said shortly. The change in subject was so sudden and unexpected that Katsuki got whiplash.

“Jesus”, he sighed, throwing his head back. Ok, this was going to be a ride.

“We worry about each other. I think we need to accept that”, Deku said promptly, to which Katsuki raised his eyebrows and tilted his head with a disbelieving look.

“Is there another option here?”, he asked sarcastically.

“No?”, Deku frowned, clearly not reading Katsuki’s tone. Great.

“I know, I was just messing with you. Again”, Katsuki pointed out.

Deku groaned, clearly helpless. Katsuki should probably stop teasing him and mocking him so much; it was evident that Deku wasn’t getting his humor, but on the other hand, Katsuki liked those little embarrassed reactions he got from it. They made him want to smile without bothering to hide it, which was very unusual for him.

“You’ll get there eventually, Deku”, he reassured the embarrassed boy, just because he looked so ashamed of himself. “You did it once before”, he added a bit nostalgically. Then, a realization dawned upon him. “By the way, why are we playing this boundary game if you have your memories back?”, he frowned.

Deku gave him a look that was half-confused, half-offended.

“Because there’s still things we need to talk about!”, he pointed out, his voice becoming a bit exasperated.

“Yeah, a whole notebook worth of them”, Katsuki nodded at the object in question, which was still held in Deku’s tight grip.

“The notebook material is almost over, by now”, Deku waved a dismissive hand, which… didn’t really add up. They had been having these talks with each other for what, less than a week? How was it possible for them to have already covered an entire notebook worth of annotations?

“What, is your handwriting huge or something?”, Katsuki frowned. “How did you occupy a whole notebook with just the shit we’ve been talking about?”

Deku hesitated.

“I – It’s like you said. I overwrite. It’s just sparse thoughts here and there, and when we talk, I give off the general idea. A summarized version of what I’ve written”, he shrugged.

Katsuki didn’t buy that shit. Deku was hiding something from him, something big. Maybe it had to do with One For All, maybe it hadn’t, but Katsuki was going to find out. He had to. Not immediately, but eventually.

“Hm”, he grunted simply, suspicion evident in his crimson eyes.

Silence fell between them. Deku shifted on his seat uncomfortably, as if he could sense Katsuki's disbelief and reluctance to take his word.

"But as I was saying", he cleared his throat awkwardly. "I'll always worry about you. You'll always worry about me. I think we need to find a way to deal with that in a healthy manner".

Katsuki scoffed. For once, Deku was right, but they both knew it was easier said than done

"Agreed", he rolled his eyes.

"So whenever you're getting worried – you can, I don't know. Text me. Or call me", Deku suggested.

Katsuki immediately scoffed and pulled a disgusted face.

"Tch. I ain't doing that", he said with a mocking tone. What was he, Deku's over-worried mom, now? He didn't need to keep tracks on him or call him like an overprotective boyfriend. And then again, Katsuki found himself kicking his own ass mentally, because *why the fuck was he thinking of himself and Deku as boyfriends, what the fuck –*

"I'm not telling you to do that", Deku pointed out, breaking him away from his increasingly panicked thoughts. "I'm just saying you can".

Katsuki felt nervous because of his own track of thoughts, which made him become defensive as an instinct.

"I ain't", he reinforced. "I'm not some helpless little thing who needs to call you just to make sure you're ok. I'm not your damn mom", he said, a bit too defensive.

Deku blinked at him, confused by this unexpectedly aggressive reaction.

"I know you're not", he pointed out. "But I think doing that would make you feel better".

Katsuki sighed. Ok, this wasn't working. Time to flip the game around.

"*You're* not gonna call me several times a day just to make sure I'm ok, will you?", he raised an eyebrow at Deku, and the boy blushed again.

"Not *several* times –", he tried to justify himself, and Katsuki shook his head with a humorous scoff.

"Deku, come on", he said with a grin. Deku really wanted to call him so much? He really missed Katsuki as much as Katsuki missed him?

"Look, I remember ok?", Deku said, but his tone was serious.

Taking a better look at him, so was his face. It was clear that Katsuki was taking this conversation with a lot more humor than Deku was, and he looked like he was about to open up his heart. So, for once, Katsuki stayed silent. The grin died down on his face and he

simply stared at Deku with a stern expression, waiting for him to continue. The time for jokes was over.

“I get that it was hard dealing with me when I woke up with no memories”, Deku started, his eyes downcast. He was staring at his own shoes as he spoke. “I get it. It must have *sucked* to you. Now that everything is in my head again, I can only imagine how terrible it felt. But now I can also remember everything that happened – and Kacchan, I’m sorry for this, but you’re very emotionally constipated”.

Katsuki felt as though he had been slapped. And therefore, he reacted like he would do if Deku had actually slapped him: angrily.

“What the fuck are you talking about?”, he barked. Now, he was far from grinning – he was glaring.

“You were touch-starved for years!”, Deku said, meeting Katsuki’s eyes with a frown on his face. “And you never dared to ask *anyone* for a hug until my literal soul was stuck with you!”

Katsuki huffed out an offended breath, narrowing his eyes at Deku.

“Now listen here you bastard –“

“I’m not trying to shove things on your face, or to make you feel bad, or, or to mock you”, Deku added quickly, sounding nervous, like he was very afraid of the possibility that Katsuki had misinterpreted his words. “I’m just saying you can *count* on me. Whatever you need, you can ask me. Always”.

Katsuki glared at him, angry. His heart was beating fast and heavy and he felt more like himself than he had in days – in weeks. It was like having an argument with Deku was what was missing in his recovery process; it made the blood pump in his veins, it made his neurons synapse with more of each other, it made his wits go back to place. Screw the dizziness and the confusion and the wet dreams, shit was about to get real.

“I’m not that type of person”, he told Deku through gritted teeth. Because he really wasn’t, was he? He didn’t ask for help, he didn’t admit to his weaknesses, he didn’t cry on his friends’ shoulders, he didn’t complain about his faults. What he did was: see something wrong, take action. That was it. If he could do something to improve the situation, good. If he couldn’t, tough shit. No use crying over spilled milk.

Deku, however, wasn’t satisfied with that answer. Of course he wasn’t.

“Well, I’m not the kind of person who sits idly around and does nothing while a friend is suffering”, he retorted, sounding equally angry. It was as if his rage was mimicking Katsuki’s, in a way. “I’m not telling you to call me and rant about your life, because I know you wouldn’t do that. I’m just telling you you can trust me”.

Katsuki averted his eyes from him, glaring at his own feet at the end of the bed. There they were again: talking about trust. He knew he could trust Deku, and Deku knew he could trust Katsuki. But could them trust themselves? Could Katsuki trust himself around Deku, when

his judgement became so clouded, his reason flied out the window, and his behavior became erratic? Could Deku trust himself around Katsuki, when he was so blinded by admiration, envy, and devotion?

“Look”, Deku continued after a few moments, when Katsuki didn’t say anything. “We both saw each other die. We’re past this kind of stuff, ok? We’re past a lot of stuff by now. So just trust me like I trust you?”, he requested, for once trying to simplify things.

Katsuki glared at Deku. The boy didn’t like the sight, because he added quickly:

“Would it be so *hard*? Do we need to have a whole argument over how you can trust me again?”, he asked a bit impatiently.

Katsuki continued to glare at him.

He didn’t want to have a whole argument. Not again, not with Deku. He was done arguing and fighting and headbutting him like a stubborn ox. So yeah, he should take those words into consideration. *Would it* be so hard to trust Deku?

No. No, it wouldn’t. And Katsuki had grown enough, he was now mature enough, to admit that to himself. Out of everyone, Deku was the one who broke the police barricade in order to get to him in the wreckage. More then that: back when he was quirkless, he was the one who went after Katsuki in order to help free him from the Sludge Villain. Katsuki knew he could trust Deku with his life, if necessary. And that was what worried him. That was what had made him push Deku away as a kid, and that was what made him push him away so many times over the past months.

Deku was an accident waiting to happen. And Katsuki didn’t want to get hurt by standing too close to him. He didn’t want to be weakened and defeated when Deku unavoidably hurt himself because of his self-sacrificial nature.

But then… Katsuki couldn’t stand the thought of being away from him. Not anymore. He had to laugh at himself when he thought back to the time when Deku had been his parasitic ghost, when he remembered the way he used to push him away. He had to laugh at himself for building a pillow fort to separate him, hell, even for making Deku sleep on the floor on those first days that felt like decades ago. He had been such an idiot. He had been such an *idiot*.

Deku had always been there, for his best, and for his worst. At this point, Katsuki knew him like the back of his hand, like the smallest nuances of his own quirk. He could recognize him by touch alone; he would know him blind, by the way his breaths came. He would know him in death, and at the end of the world.

So yeah. He might end up getting hurt, but he was done running from it. He was done running from Deku. Doctor Matsuo had said so herself – Katsuki was a hedgehog, Deku was a hedgehog. But the hedgehog’s spines only hurt the other when they were afraid. If they could both relax around each other, neither of them would hurt themselves.

Katsuki had watched Deku die. Deku had watched Katsuki die. If they had both conquered their worst fears, they had no reason to be afraid around each other anymore.

“I trust you”, he said finally. Sincerely. Deku had no idea what was going inside his mind and his heart, but from the way Katsuki spoke the words, he hoped the nerd got the message. He allowed himself to show vulnerability for one rare instance, and he showed Deku, through the look in his eyes, that he was saying the truth.

Deku swallowed dry and nodded at him, grateful.

“Thank you”, Deku said with sincerity.

Katsuki took a deep breath. If they were going to do this, then they had to be honest.

“I just don’t know how to do this sort of thing you want me to do”, he admitted with a shrug, hoping Deku would understand. Because yeah, he might be a hedgehog, but that was all he knew how to be. If Deku couldn’t accept that, if he kept expecting Katsuki would change into a turtle, with its tough carapace and no spines… then they wouldn’t work out. As friends, or as something else.

Something more.

Deku frowned.

“What thing?”, he asked.

“Calling you, keeping in touch”, Katsuki explained, serious. “I’m not that guy. And I don’t want you to go around creating expectations for me to fulfill again, otherwise we’ll end up at the same spot from last time”, he added with honesty.

“You mean arguing our lungs away during a villain invasion?”, Deku asked with a resemblance of a sad smile.

Katsuki nodded.

“Yeah, exactly”.

Deku’s shoulders sagged as he sighed. He seemed a bit disappointed, which sent a spark of hurt across Katsuki’s chest.

“I understand”, he said sadly.

Katsuki felt his sadness. It was like they were mimicking each other’s emotions again, but this sadness was his, and his only.

“I can’t be who you want me to be, Deku”, he added, serious and firm, even though his heart was aching. “All I can be is me. And I’m angry, and grumpy, and short-tempered. I go feral over the tiniest shit you can imagine. And this is who I am”.

Can you take me for who I am?

Deku studied his face for a while, empathy written all over his eyes. Then, in a surge of adrenaline, he reached forward and grabbed Kacchan’s hand.

Katsuki stared down at their conjoined hands, his heart leaping in his chest. He became more aware of his surroundings, of time itself, and of his own mortality. He had almost died. He had almost lost his life, and now he was holding hands with Deku. It felt simple, and it felt as hard as quantum physics. But as confused as he was, he knew he didn't want to pull away from the touch. Not this time.

"I know, Kacchan", Deku said with a smile, even though his eyes were sad. "I don't want you to change".

Katsuki huffed in disbelief at this, turning his face away.

"Are you sure? Because you keep making demands –", he accused, but it was half-hearted.

"I'm not making demands", Deku interrupted him. "I'm just…"

A sigh.

"You're right. I might be a bit of a control freak", Deku admitted.

Katsuki raised his head to look at him. Maybe there was hope after all.

"Newsflash", he said, just for the sake of being the smart-head of that situation.

"Oh, stop it", Deku rolled his eyes, but there was affection in the gesture.

There was a pause, a comfortable one. Katsuki stared again at their intertwined hands, trying to make sense of what he was feeling in that moment. His heart was still pumping with renewed energy inside his chest, as it had been ever since Deku reached out to him. He could almost remember, as if in a dream of a dream, the image of their joined hands accompanied by the sound of a river.

"But really", Deku added after a few moments of quiet. "Sorry for trying to tell you what to do. I just wanted you to know that – you can count on me", he repeated himself.

Katsuki offered him a crooked little teasing smile at this.

"I know that. Even when I was trying to get rid of you, you wouldn't get the hell out of my case. I know I can count on you".

Deku smiled back at him.

"But I mean for *anything*".

Katsuki looked deep into Deku's eyes.

"I know that", he said. And he really knew.

Deku blinked and his cheeks became a bit pink.

"Good. T-That's… good", he stuttered, nervous.

A knock echoed on the door.

“Hello”, a nurse greeted, popping her head into the room and smiling softly at Deku. “Time for his meds”, she gestured, opening the door all the way.

Deku quickly pulled his hand away from Katsuki’s, breaking their contact so fast that it made it look like he had been burned. He didn’t meet Katsuki’s eyes as he got to his feet, face going from pink to red in a matter of seconds. Katsuki missed the contact with Deku’s skin; it had felt hypnotic, somehow, as if he could remember all his forgotten dreams if he just could touch Deku a little longer.

“Guess this is my cue to leave”, Deku sighed, grabbing his notebook. He finally met Katsuki’s eyes again, biting his lower lip. “Same time tomorrow?”

Katsuki scoffed.

“I ain’t going anywhere”, he said simply.

Deku smiled.

“See you, Kacchan. Be nice to the staff”.

“Don’t tell me what to do”.

“Ok”.

“Ok”.

The nurse started to administer Katsuki’s pain medication and he lied there very still on his bed, staring at the ceiling.

“He’s a nice boy, isn’t he?”, she asked him a few moments after Deku’s departure.

“Hm?”, Katsuki hummed, distracted.

“That boy visiting you”, she clarified. “I noticed he comes here every day”.

Katsuki raised an eyebrow and sniffed.

“Yeah”, he said shortly, not knowing how to engage into the small talk.

“He really cares about you, I can tell”, she nodded to herself. “It’s nice to be able to count on someone like that”.

Katsuki continued to stare at the ceiling, his good, un-casted arm thrown behind his head. He didn’t know if this was an effect of his medication, but he found himself saying:

“I care about him too”.

The nurse gave him a tiny smile, and didn’t say anything else. Katsuki became too sleepy to see her leave, but even if he had been paying attention, he wouldn’t have noticed her absence.

All he could think about was Deku, and whether or not his lips were soft.

"You… You want me to call you… Katsuki?"

"Don' like tha', D'ku".

"Yeah", Deku chuckled wetly, but the sound was more melancholic than anything. "I don't like that, either".

"B't y're still a li'r", Katsuki wheezed softly.

A pregnant pause.

"I never lied to you in my life", Deku said, sincerity and sobriety suddenly overwhelming his tone. "If anything, you're the only person who I never lie to".

Katsuki's good eye averted from the sky to focus on his face.

"I really didn't know how to say it, before", Deku shrugged, his hands still pressing down on Kacchan's wound. "But I was kind of forced to learn it. When I did speech therapy".

Katsuki blinked at him.

"B-But… Well. It feels wrong, to call you anything other than 'Kacchan' at this point", he admitted, looking away with a sad expression.

A few moments passed.

"Feels wr'ng t'call y' Izuk', too", Katsuki admitted, voice raspy and constrained.

Deku looked at him with tears in his eyes.

"C-Can…", he swallowed dry. "Can you say that again?"

"Y' r'ly wan' me to?", Katsuki slurred, wheezing.

Izuku just lowered his head, neither confirming nor denying.

"Iz… Izuku", Katsuki wheezed out.

Izuku…

Katsuki woke up with a gasp, blinking.

He rubbed a tired hand on his face and on his eyes, yawning loudly and sighing after that. He tried to deduce what time it was, but there was no way to tell. He almost felt frustrated, but then he remembered he had his phone back. He turned on the bed slowly, carefully, reaching for the device on the nightstand before returning to his previous position, lying on his back.

The clock in the phone told him it was only 10 p.m. That was later than his usual bedtime, but still early for his friends. Katsuki saw there were several messages in different chats, but his eyes searched for that one familiar name that kept popping in his mind even in his sleep.

Izuku. Deku.

He couldn't tell if the dream was a memory or a fabrication of his mind. He knew, now, that Deku had gone after him in the wreckage of the building, so there was a chance Katsuki was really recalling a flashback of what had happened, since he supposed Deku must have talked to him while he was injured. But the uncertainty – the impossibility of being sure of what was real and what was fake – was driving him to the edge.

He opened his chat with Deku and stared at it. He started to type down a message.

Did you call me by my first name back when we were at the wreckage?

He stared at the screen, thumb hovering above the send button. Something about the message didn't feel right. Shaking his head after a few seconds, Katsuki erased the whole thing and started typing again.

What did you think of me calling you Izuku?

He twisted his nose, displeased. Still not good. He erased it.

Are your lips soft?

"Ugh", he groaned at himself, erasing the message again. He went back to staring at the screen blankly, urging to start a conversation with Deku but not knowing how to.

He bit his lower lip, pensive. He started typing again.

I'm curious about something

Before he could think too much about it, he hit send. Depending on Deku's answer, he'd think of what to say.

The reply came a few seconds later, almost as if Deku had been waiting for the text.

From: Deku

What is it?

Katsuki thought for a while, scavenging his brain for the proper thing to say. Asking about Deku's lips would be creepy and weird, so it was a no-go. Mentioning the name thing would be embarrassing in case it had been just a dream and not a memory. Katsuki decided to settle for something older, something from those six months when they didn't talk or even acknowledged each other's existence.

From: Kacchan

The shirt I gave you as a birthday present. Did you like it?

Deku is typing…

Deku is typing…

Katsuki huffed, rolling his eyes. Maybe Deku was doing the same thing he had done – typing and erasing the message several times over before hitting send. The thought that Deku was as nervous to talk – but also as eager – made Katsuki feel a little less out of his depth.

From: Deku

I loved it

From: Deku

It instantly became one of my favorites

A tinge of jealousy appeared inside his chest.

From: Kacchan

One of

From: Kacchan

The audacity

From: Deku

It was on my top five shirts

From: Deku

The other four were gifts from All Might Kacchan, you can't compete with that

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

From: Kacchan

The hell I can't

From: Kacchan

If I want to surpass him as number one hero I should be able to do something as simple as giving you your favorite shirt

From: Deku

That turned out sweeter than you had intended, isn't it?

Katsuki felt heat rising to his face.

From: Kacchan

Shut up

From: Deku

You can still give me my favorite shirt

From: Deku

The one you gave me got ruined, back at the wreckage

That made Katsuki frown. He couldn't really make sense of the many flashes inside his head, they were all too messy and out of order to be comprehensible, but there was one memory… one flash…

"D-Deku…?"

“Yes, Kacchan?”

“Wh’r’s y’r shirt?”

“I had to take it out”.

“’rent ya… cold?”

“No, I’m just fine. Why? Are you cold?”

He pursed his lips, trying to figure out what to say.

From: Kacchan

I didn’t know that

From: Deku

I didn’t tell you

From: Deku

But now I’m giving you the chance to become competitive over a shirt

Katsuki smiled.

From: Kacchan

I’ll beat All Might’s ass

From: Deku

Don’t say stuff like that!

From: Kacchan

Don’t tell me what to say

From: Deku

Oh, yeah, right. Sorry

Katsuki rolled his eyes. He appreciated how fast the nerd was to respect his boundaries, but really, could he not *see* that this was clearly a joke? Katsuki always told people not to tell him what to do. It was kind of his thing, his catchphrase. For someone who kept such a close track of him, Deku was kind of a thickhead sometimes.

From: Kacchan

It's a figure of speech Deku

From: Kacchan

Really, I don't know how you do it

From: Deku

I'm sorryyyy

From: Deku

I'll work on it

From: Kacchan

You're a lost cause

Katsuki set the phone aside and sighed. His injury wasn't aching or throbbing, which told him that there were still enough pain meds in his system to dull the pain. That, or maybe he was finally healing and no longer in need of that shitty medication Recovery Girl kept pumping into him.

Katsuki was so tired of feeling groggy and sleepy all the time, and he hated how his thought process slowed down. But overall, he was also feeling calmer and more rational than usual, so maybe the medications weren't all that bad. He didn't want to have another panic attack ever again, and the thought of having one in front of Deku sent a spark of fear to his chest. *How humiliating.*

He decided to get up and get himself some water. There were fluids keeping him hydrated through the IV – he knew that much because he constantly needed to use the bathroom even though he wasn't drinking anything. But pumping liquids directly into his veins did nothing to soothe the dry raspy feeling on his tongue and his throat, which meant he needed a good old-fashioned glass of water.

He felt dizzy as soon as he got up. That kept happening to him, ever since he woke up in the hospital for the first time. Leaning one hand on the bed for support, he started to walk slowly to Recovery Girl's office, where he supposed he'd be able to find a cup of water.

He was right. At the corner of the room, near the window, there was a water fountain and some paper cups. Katsuki limped his way there – he couldn't really walk straight because of the way his stitches pulled at his skin – and grabbed himself some water with his good hand. He drank one cup, then another, and after that he felt satisfied.

He took the chance that he was there to gaze out Recovery Girl's window. He didn't really get much of a view from his hospital bed, but here, at the healing hero's office, he could see the UA grounds showered in the moonlight. The window was closed, so he couldn't feel the night breeze, but just the sight of it was calming and relaxing. Katsuki felt at home there, or at least more comfortable than he had been at the hospital, with all their bright lights and loud corridors. Soon enough, even the rush of adrenaline he had felt for talking to Deku was disappearing, giving place to a feeling of peace and quiet.

After watching the night for a few moments, Katsuki limped back to his bed, dragging the metal handler that was supporting the bag with his fluids and medication with him. He made it halfway across the room before he collapsed.

He didn't really know what happened. One moment, he was walking, the next, he was face down on the floor. Recovery Girl had retired for the night, so she wasn't there to scold him for his little errand for water. Usually, a nurse stayed at the medical bay to watch over the patients, but she mustn't have heard Katsuki falling. He was grateful for that small miracle – he didn't want anyone to know about this incident, lest they treat him like he was even more of an invalid.

His forehead was throbbing, though, probably because he must have slammed it on the floor upon falling. Katsuki hoped it didn't bruise or swell, lest it reveal the incident that occurred during his little nightly endeavor. He didn't feel any dizzier or slower than usual, so he probably – luckily – didn't have a(nother) concussion.

Slowly, and with a pained grunt, Katsuki got to his knees, then to his feet. He swayed and stumbled as he tried to regain his balance, before he bent down and picked up his fluid bag. He set it into an upright position and checked the bag to see if it had broken, but everything seemed fine with it. He then checked his hand, where the IV was inserted, and found that thankfully it hadn't broken out of his skin.

With a sigh and another pained grunt – because his impalement injury was throbbing, now, probably disrupted during his fall –, Katsuki resumed his walk back to bed. By the time he got near it, the room was spinning around him, and he only had the strength to fall against the mattress, his legs dangling off the edge, and his IV hand tilted back as if not to rip it out. His broken arm was buried beneath his own weight.

He made an effort to adjust himself on the bed, his covers askew and dangling off to the floor. He was sweating and shaking by the time he got on his back, and he felt really, really weak. His head hurt and his heart was in a frenzy; he could feel the palpitations against his chest. Katsuki didn't know what was wrong with him, but he knew that this wasn't normal, and this wasn't a side effect of his concussion, either. There was something else going on, something he couldn't put his finger on or name.

He ended up falling asleep – or rather, passing out from exhaustion.

And that was when everything changed.

Katsuki stared at Izuku through one half-lidded eye. He was so close to him.

And to think he used to believe Izuku looked down on him. To think he'd been an idiot to the point of believing Deku would ever belittle him. Those seemed like the far away memories of a faraway boy who didn't know any better. A boy who was stupid, and arrogant, and self-centered, and who didn't know that there was so much more inside him than rage and anger.

Izuku was really close, now. If he craned his neck, he would manage to brush his tongue against his and pass One For All back for him. That had to be enough, right? Enough saliva, enough DNA?

Katsuki's heart skipped another beat. And another. It was starting to do that more frequently, actually. Which indicated he didn't have much time left.

He closed his eye. He didn't want to see Izuku's disappointed expression when he reached the faux conclusion that Katsuki was giving up. Because he wasn't giving up. But he also couldn't risk it.

"Kacch–", Izuku tried to ask when Katsuki's eye slipped closed, fearing he had passed out again, but he was interrupted by Katsuki's mouth crashing against his.

Katsuki didn't open his eyes. All the energy he had left was put into lifting his head and brushing his tongue on Izuku's lips.

Izuku's lips were chapped and dry. They weren't soft. Why had Katsuki dreamed that they were soft? Was that his secret wish, his secret assumption?

He felt, more than heard, Izuku's little gasp of surprise, and took the opportunity to slip his tongue into his mouth. The only thing he could currently feel amidst all that numbness and cold was the warmth of Izuku's own tongue, which remained still as Katsuki's own curled against it.

Katsuki hoped this would work and that One For All would go back to its true owner. He didn't really know if there was a proper way to pass it on, but he was really counting on his

sheer will to get rid of the thing and give it back to Izuku to do the trick. And in a split moment of probable blood-loss-induced delusion, Katsuki found himself thinking that this would probably still feel nice in another situation.

Nice. It felt so nice. Deku warm against him, tongue curling with his, exploring his mouth, their teeth bumping together in their rush to get to touch each other, fingers tracing bare skin, breaths warming each other's upper lips, hands intertwining and connecting and just grabbing for each other, keeping each other close…

Hands.

One of his tiny childish hands supported his weight into a sitting position, while the other was outstretched upwards, holding on to another equally tiny, childish one. He looked up and found the child version of Izuku looking at him with concern, holding his hand into his.

Can we please agree to just talk this out when neither of us are dying?

Will you try to remember?

I promise I'll try.

In the rare moments when you let your other feelings out, you can be very honest.

Deku! Matte yo, Deku!

Katsuki's eyes shot wide open.

He was on the floor, legs twisted beneath him, orange sparks running across his skin. His bed was thrown across the room, as if someone very strong had kicked it and made it fall to the side. The nightstand hadn't fared much better – it was also thrown on the floor, broken, having received the worst hand of Katsuki's outburst.

The nurse who was on duty rushed into the room to find Katsuki breathing hard and fast, one of his hands clutching the front of his hospital gown. She took one wide-eyed look at the bed, which was lying on its side, and at the panting boy on the floor. This time, his IV drip had been ripped off his hand, and blood was dripping to the floor. Hands. Deku's hand.

Katsuki tried to say something – he tried to justify himself –, but before he could, the nurse turned on her heels and ran back the way she had come from. *Great, she'll probably fetch Recovery Girl*, Katsuki thought to himself, so instead of wasting time and making things look even worse on himself, he got to his feet and decided to clean up his own mess.

He lost balance as he walked to the bed, leaning heavily on it when his vision started to swim. His legs gave out and he collapsed again, leaning half of his weight against the fallen mattress.

There was so much on his head. He had kissed Deku. It couldn't have been a dream; it didn't feel like a dream. He had kissed Deku and he had passed One For All back to him through saliva. That was how he got it back – that was why he felt so awkward telling Katsuki the truth.

Fuck. *Fuck.* Things would never be the same between them. How could they? Katsuki, the one who didn't care about romance, the one who didn't know what love was, had kissed his childhood friend turned rival turned friend, and he had *liked it.* Because he had liked it, hadn't he? He had wanted to try it again, when he was better.

But did he still want that? To kiss Deku in a different scenario, a scenario that didn't involve death and blood and impalement? If he did, why did he? At what point, at what step of the way, did he become a person who wanted to kiss Deku and hold his hand? At what point did his hatred go away? At what point did he become infatuated?

"Bakugou", Recovery Girl called, rushing to his side as fast as she could with her tiny cane. She crouched down beside him at the same time the nursed turned on the lights, illuminating the room. "What happened?"

"Sorry", was all Katsuki could say, voice hoarse. "I'm – sorry".

"Don't fret, my boy", she said in a firm tone that was also gentle. "Just tell me what's going on".

Katsuki swallowed dry, compulsively. He was still breathing heavily, and his heart was a hummingbird in his ribcage.

"M-Matsuo", he croaked out, leaning heavily against the lopsided bed. "I need – I n-need Doctor Matsuo".

Recovery Girl was frowning at him, her wrinkled lips forming a thin line. But she nodded, of course she did – one look at his state was enough to tell her that this was beyond her healing quirk.

"Let me examine you", she said, taking his bloodied hand. "Here, let me take you to another room".

"C-Can't", Katsuki slurred. "Dizzy".

Recovery Girl paused.

"When did the dizziness start?"

"I got up. To get water", he swallowed. "Came back and collapsed. Went to sleep. Had a dream… A nightmare", he lied. Recovery Girl didn't need to know he had dreamt about *kissing Deku*. "Woke up like this".

Recovery Girl nodded.

"I see", she said patiently. "What do you feel when you are dizzy? Does it happen while you are relaxed?"

Katsuki frowned.

"What?"

“Have you been feeling calmer? More relaxed than usual?”

Katsuki blinked, thinking about it.

“Y-Yeah”.

“And are those the moments when you feel dizzy?”

Katsuki frowned.

“I… I don’t know”.

Recovery Girl pursed her lips.

“We can talk about this later. For now, I’ll call more people to help you get to bed. Ok?”

Katsuki didn’t respond. His eyes were unfocused and droopy.

“Bakugou?”, Recovery Girl called.

Katsuki passed out again, his body becoming slack against the bottom of the bed.

When Katsuki woke up again, it was morning.

The back of his head buzzed with that weird feeling you get when someone’s observing you. Katsuki frowned and turned to look at the corner of the room, where Aizawa sensei was watching over him.

“Bakugou”, he greeted simply.

Katsuki hissed a bit as he propped himself into a sitting position.

“Sensei”, he greeted back.

He still felt weak, but less so than the last time he had been awake. He was back to lying in a bed – one of his hands, the one from which the IV had been ripped, was covered by a bandage. There was a new access on his other hand – the broken one –, and Katsuki followed the wire up to a bag of fluids beside his bed.

“How are you feeling?”, Aizawa asked, his face as impassive as ever.

Katsuki was silent for a moment.

“Better than before”, he admitted, turning back to his teacher. “But still…”

Aizawa waited for him to continue. When he didn’t, he said:

“Still what?”

Katsuki twisted his nose in disgust, looking away from his teacher. He didn’t want to be so honest, but a memory convinced him to speak up.

I’m your teacher. I’m here to help you and mold you into the competent pro I know you can become. I’m the last person in the world you should have to put an act to. More than anyone, I need to know what your limits are so I can know how far to push you.

“Weak”, he said in a small voice, ashamed.

Aizawa nodded.

“That’s normal, all things considered”.

Katsuki sealed his lips tightly and looked downward. A few moments of silence passed, where neither of them said anything.

“You know what? I don’t think so”, Katsuki said eventually.

There was a pause.

“Why not?”

Katsuki tilted his head up to face his teacher, a stern look on his face.

“I was supposed to be getting better. But every time I stand up, every time I do anything – I end up all dizzy and weak and fainty. And yeah, I was impaled and all that, but that was two weeks ago. So either I’m not getting better, or…”, he shook his head.

Aizawa raised an eyebrow.

“Or what?”, he encouraged his student.

“Or there’s something else wrong with me. Something no one’s telling me”.

Aizawa nodded. His arms were crossed above his chest in a reserved stance; he took a step closer to Katsuki’s new bed so that he could stand by his feet. The look on his face told Katsuki his teacher was there for some serious business – which rarely turned out well, based on Katsuki’s previous experiences.

“There’s something we need to discuss”, he announced, and great. So there *was* something wrong with him that no one had told him about.

What was it about UA and all their dirty little secrets? Why could they never be straight fucking forward about anything, especially when it involved their student's welfare?

Katsuki huffed out a disappointed breath, but he leaned back against his pillows. He gave Aizawa sensei a half-glare, half-knowing look, waiting for what was to come. Whatever this was, shit was about to get real.

Aizawa hesitated, which was uncommon for him.

"Ever since you were taken in and went through surgery, you've been given several medications", he started. "Their goal was to mostly stop your pain, prevent the wound from becoming infected, and help you sleep".

Katsuki nodded.

"However, you went through two severe panic attacks", Aizawa continued, ignoring the way Katsuki flinched in shame at the mention. "They disrupted your body and your recovery process. The stress you were feeling was straining your body beyond its limit and taking its focus away from healing itself. You were making yourself worse".

Katsuki narrowed his eyes.

Aizawa took a deep breath and sighed.

"The doctors asked your parents for permission to add a specific medication to your cocktail", he continued. "They consulted me and Recovery Girl and we all reached the conclusion that it would be for the best if you didn't learn about this until you were faring better, or at least faring well enough to have this conversation without straining yourself. As you can see, that didn't happen. You didn't get better, you got worse. And we only found out why now".

Katsuki blinked at his teacher.

"Ok", he said, serious. "What was the medication?"

"Clonazepam", Aizawa responded without missing a beat.

Katsuki stared at him.

"It's a medication used, amongst many things, in anxiety disorders –"

"I know what it's for", Katsuki interrupted him. "I just don't know why you think I need it".

Aizawa sighed again, tiredly.

"Bakugou…"

"I don't suffer from anxiety", he said in a defensive tone. He had had that talk with Doctor Matsuo already, and if she hadn't managed to convince him, Aizawa sensei wouldn't either.

Aizawa closed his eyes for a brief moment before focusing back on his student.

“Right. I’m not qualified to have this discussion with you”, he admitted. “Which is why your therapist is waiting outside to talk to you, if you’re ready. Recovery Girl said you asked for her, and your parents agreed that having a session with her would be in your best interest”.

Katsuki remembered the moment with embarrassed precision. He was also reminded of his dream/memory with Deku and his stupid lips, which made his heart beat faster. Right. He needed to focus on one thing at once.

“But I don’t get it”, he said, confused. “Why did you say I got worse? Was it the clonazepam making me dizzy and weak and all that?”

Aizawa sighed.

“Yes and no”, he said. “What I’m about to tell you is information we just learned about this morning. Recovery Girl and I had our suspicions about the source of your dizziness and overall ill feeling, but we wanted to investigate it further and find a conclusive answer before we brought this to you”.

“And did you?”, Katsuki asked promptly. “Find a conclusive answer?

“Yes”, Aizawa nodded. “As it turns out, it isn’t the medicine making you ill. It’s your quirk”.

Katsuki blinked at him. He was silent for a moment.

“… What?”

“To put it easily”, his teacher said. “Part of your quirk is to secrete a nitroglycerin-like substance that gets ignited by the explosions on the palm of your hands”.

Katsuki nodded.

“Your body is used to fabricating a lot of this secretion. It is common, in case such as yours, for the body to adapt to the quirk as the person grows. The earlier the quirk manifests, the earlier your body starts to adapt. Now, to test your attention during your biochemistry classes: what are the effects of nitroglycerin poisoning in the human body?”

Katsuki narrowed his eyes, thinking back to his lessons for a moment. He scanned his memory for the answers that were buried somewhere in his brain.

“Palpitation”, he said. “Lowered heartbeat. Dizziness… Shortness of breath…”, he started to frown.

Aizawa nodded.

“Fainting, headaches, and weakness are also on the list”, he added. “Now, most of these symptoms overlap with the side effects of head trauma. Do you see why we took so long to identify it?”

Katsuki shook his head, frowning in confusion.

“I don’t get it. Are you saying I have nitroglycerin poisoning?”

Aizawa nodded.

“Something like that. Your sweat isn’t pure nitroglycerin, but the substance is very similar to it. And therefore, so are the side effects of the poisoning”.

“But that doesn’t make sense”, Katsuki protested. “My body’s been fabricating this shit my entire life and I never felt dizzy or weak or any of that before”.

Aizawa nodded again.

“Enter: the clonazepam”, he said. “Are you familiar with its effects on the body?”

Katsuki squinted.

“Not really”, he admitted. “I just know it’s prescribed to people with anxiety”.

Aizawa nodded.

“It works as a mild sedative. We used it to calm you down so that you didn’t have any more panic attacks, and so that you could get some sleep and rest to heal yourself. But that brings me back to our talk about quirk manifestation and the adaptation of the body. Do you happen to know how your and your mother’s body adapted to the substance you secrete overtime, so that you wouldn’t get poisoned and pass out every day?”

Katsuki frowned. He shook his head.

Aizawa sighed.

“Nitroglycerin lowers the heart rate. But your heart rate has always been normal, hasn’t it?”

Katsuki nodded.

“That’s because you and your mother are constantly stressed out. The permanent stress, which would increase a normal person’s heart rate to a detectible difference, makes up for the low heartbeat caused by the nitroglycerin-like substance. Your hotheaded attitude is what’s been keeping you both healthy all those years”.

Katsuki stared at him. His face was blank.

“We hadn’t taken this into consideration, however, when we introduced the clonazepam to the equation”, Aizawa continued. “It reduced your stress levels considerably, which then lowered your heartbeat and caused the dizzy spells and the fainting. We didn’t detect this on the blood tests because your results all came back perfectly normal. You’re still secreting the exact amount of nitroglycerin as you always did. The difference wasn’t on your biology, it was on your mental state”.

Katsuki continued to blink stupidly at him.

“So what you’re saying is that I need to be stressed out to stay alive?”

Aizawa sighed.

“That’s what your psychologist is going discuss with you”, he provided. “… Amongst other things”.

Katsuki shook his head, trying to clear his thoughts.

“My parents agreed to this? Do they know?”

Aizawa nodded.

“They knew about the clonazepam and consented to its use. They, as well as us, had no idea about the side effects on your body specifically. I will contact them as soon as I leave here and inform them of everything we’ve found out. I wanted to clear things up with you, first”.

Katsuki huffed out an amused breath. *That* was a first.

“So the only loser who didn’t know I was being drugged was me?”

Aizawa sighed tiredly.

“Don’t make this harder than this has to be”, he said, a little impatiently. “You weren’t being drugged; you were being medicated. We were just trying to prevent you from hurting yourself because of a condition you were unable to control. No one ever saw the medication as a permanent solution, as none of your other medication will be. You won’t take antibiotics forever, and the same applies to the clonazepam”.

Katsuki narrowed his eyes. His teacher sounded sincere and his argument made sense, but Katsuki still felt a little betrayed. He wished he had just been told things, rather than being treated like a crazy person. He wished he’d stop having these panic attacks without the intervention of a drug.

“I understand you need to take your time to digest this”, Aizawa concluded. “And I’ll be comprehensive if you are upset at us for making this choice for you. But you’re still a minor, and you are UA’s responsibility. We wouldn’t let one of our students suffer, or even die, just because of he might be upset at us for making a choice on his behalf”.

“You’re right, I’m a minor”, Katsuki retorted. “Which means it’s my parents’ consent that counts. You could have told me and I could have said no, and you’d still be able to drug me against my will, if *they* had consented to it. Instead, you chose not to tell me anything until now. You chose not to say anything until things started to go wrong”.

Aizawa tilted his head away. If Katsuki didn’t know him, he would have said he looked almost ashamed.

“But I get it”, Katsuki scoffed, self-deprecating. “I’m the hothead, right? I’m the stubborn one”, he shrugged. “You guys didn’t want to have me throwing a tantrum in the middle of the hospital every time a damn nurse came to pump me up with meds”.

Aizawa met his eyes. Katsuki sounded sincere. He was displaying raw emotion. And he really meant those words – he knew he would have given his caretakers a hard time if he had known about the clonazepam. Doing things behind his back had been a necessity, because his teacher, his parents, and everyone knew that he was a stubborn son of a bitch. For once, he wasn’t proud of that.

“So yeah, I won’t hold a grudge against y’all”, he concluded, averting his eyes from the teacher. “But it’s fucked up you guys didn’t tell me about it”.

Aizawa studied his student’s face for a while. Then, he nodded.

“If you compromise to be this mature in the future, I can compromise to be more honest. On behalf of the school”.

Katsuki huffed out another amused breath.

“That’d be a first. I’m still pissed about how you guys acted when it was Deku’s ass on the line”.

Aizawa shifted his weight from one foot to another.

“We wronged you then”, he admitted, tilting his chin up. “And for that I am sorry”.

Katsuki looked at his teacher.

“I’ve taken his example, as well as yours, to the board. We will discuss how we can be more in touch with our students in the future. More open, and more honest”.

Katsuki narrowed his eyes a bit.

“It’s slow, but it’s progress”, Aizawa concluded. “And any progress counts, in the end”.

Katsuki stared at him for a moment before he nodded.

“Is Doctor Matsuo really outside?”, he asked.

Aizawa nodded.

“She’s waiting for when you’re ready to speak. I understand if our conversation is already too much –“

“It’s not”, Katsuki interrupted. “You can tell her I’m ready to see her”.

Aizawa nodded. Without another word, he walked away and left the room.

Katsuki didn't know what to think about what he had just been told. He was taking anxiety medication… and his own quirk was making him sick? And his parents had consented to that, without telling a word to him, just when he thought he was getting on better terms with his mom? There was so much to unfold, so much to talk about, and yet the one thing he couldn't stop thinking about was stupid Deku and the stupid kiss.

God. What the fuck was going on with him? When had he turned into a lovesick teenager who prioritized a kiss over his own damn health?

The door to the room opened, revealing Doctor Matsuo. Katsuki was sucker-punched out of his mental breakdown.

He hadn't seen her in weeks, but it felt like a lifetime. He had skipped his last proper appointment with her in order to go to that damn museum, and sure, it had been less than a month since he last saw her, but so much had changed in that meantime that Katsuki felt like a completely different person. And Doctor Matsuo looked like it.

He couldn't pinpoint exactly what had changed about her, but she seemed… distraught. Not in a bad way, or even an unnerving way, but in a way that made her look older, somehow. Her eyes were tired and very worried as she approached him; she was clutching her bag close to her side as she marched her way down to his bed. She was so tense and her posture was so stiff that she looked more stressed out than Katsuki felt.

"Doc", he said simply, but, to his surprise, she dove straight into a hug, holding him close to her chest.

Katsuki remained very still for a moment, taking in the comforting scent of her perfume before his good hand moved out of instinct and touched her back. He closed his eyes and nestled his head on her shoulder. For once, he didn't feel invaded or uncomfortable by the touch – this woman was practically his emotional cane at this point. She was Katsuki's last hope at figuring out everything that was happening to his body and to his heart.

Doctor Matsuo broke their hug and pulled back with a scrunched-up face and tears in her eyes. She had her hands squeezing both of Katsuki's shoulders while she looked at him, trying to read his face.

Katsuki frowned at her – she was usually so professional and collected. If she was losing her shit, should he lose his shit to? What was going on? What was he supposed to do?

"I'm sorry for being so emotional", she sniffed, letting go of him and pulling the visitor's chair closer to the bed. She sat down on the edge of it, her body leaning forwards. "It's just…", she took a deep breath and put on a calm façade, eyes averted to the ceiling while she cleared her tears away with her own thumbs. Once she was done, she smiled reassuringly. "We've both been through a lot, haven't we?"

Katsuki continued to stare at her with a frown.

"… Yeah, I guess", he said, suspicious and confused with her unexpected behavior.

“I’m fine. You don’t need to worry about me”, she reassured him, noticing his discomfort. “I was crying because I’m happy to see you”.

Katsuki’s frown deepened. He never really understood why some people cried from happiness.

Doctor Matsuo smiled again, even though her eyes were red-rimmed. She looked at him.

“I have to say”, she started, her shaking voice becoming more collected. “I thought we wouldn’t have the chance to speak again. The school board considered finding you a new therapist, since I became personally involved with you”.

Katsuki blinked at her, dread slowly pooling at his stomach and making him freeze. Another therapist? Having to go through the process of opening himself and his thoughts to a complete stranger? *Again*?

“*What*?”, he asked, nervous and indignant. Before he could freak out, she pointed a calming hand at him.

“I explained the situation and the complexity of your case. I told them that it would be for the best if I was the one who continued the sessions with you, since you’re familiar with me and my methods. Plus, introducing a stranger into a complex case such as yours, right after a life-threatening injury and another traumatic experience… Would be bad for everyone”, she nodded.

Katsuki continued to frown at her.

“What do you mean, you became personally involved with me?”, he asked, not really following.

She dropped her hand, folding it above the other on her lap, and her shoulders sagged.

“You saved my son’s life”, she stated simply.

Katsuki just stared at her for a moment before narrowing his eyes.

“In my defense, I didn’t even know he was your son”, he pointed out.

Doctor Matsuo nodded.

“I know, he told me. He also said that you have plenty of coins to add to your swear jar”, she narrowed her eyes back at him, playfully.

Katsuki smiled and tried to hide it by lowering his head.

“But I explained this to the board”, she continued in a light tone. “I assured them I wouldn’t let what happened interfere on the way I tended to you, and that I wouldn’t display any kind of favoritism during the sessions just because you saved my son’s life”.

Katsuki nodded, forcing himself to calm down. If she was here, talking to him, that meant she was still his therapist, right? She had made them change their minds. She had it under control. Katsuki had to believe that.

A comfortable silence fell between them. For a moment, Doctor Matsuo just stared at him, looking like she was trying to figure out where to start their conversation. She no longer looked like the emotional wreck she had been barely a minute before, but rather the calm professional he was used to seeing. He kind of wished he could learn to have her emotional maturity instead of freaking out all the time. Even though, from what it seemed, freaking out was the very thing keeping his body working.

In her defense, Katsuki didn't know where to start, either. A half-an-hour-long appointment didn't seem enough to cover up everything that had happened in those past weeks.

"First of all, before we start, I need to thank you", she said, breaking the silence with a decisive look. "My son is alive thanks to you. A lot of people are".

Katsuki sighed, blinking at her. For someone who thought so much of himself, he didn't really know how to respond to the praise. Saying something in the lines of "I know I'm fucking awesome" didn't sit right with him, not in that moment, and not in a conversation with someone who knew so much about his insecurities and his problems.

"You don't have to say anything in response to that", she added, probably sensing Katsuki's hesitation. "And I know that what happened must have taken a toll on you. Your teacher, Aizawa-san, was obliged to inform me of your panic attacks back at the hospital. Do you want to start our talk with that?", she tilted her head, curious.

Katsuki grimaced.

"No", he said firmly, without hesitation.

She licked her lips and nodded, keeping her head low.

"I wanted you to know that your reaction was perfectly normal and perfectly expectable after what you went through", she reassured him. "It doesn't define you as a person, and with proper attention, we can counter this and ensure it won't happen again. But for that, we're going to need to acknowledge it first. That includes talking about it, even if it takes you out of your comfort zone. Do you understand?"

Katsuki rubbed his good hand on his face. Comfort zone. Did he even have one anymore?

"However, I understand that everything that happened is still very recent, so I won't expect you to be ready to talk about it just yet", she added. "Instead, I'll start with our usual: how are you feeling?"

Katsuki swallowed dry. He wanted to use the same answer he had given Deku, *look at me, I'm in a hospital bed after a pipe impaled me, how do you think I'm feeling, etc.*

“I don’t know anymore”, he admitted instead with a shrug, after thinking for a few moments. She always seemed to know exactly how to make him be honest. “I thought I was fine, but apparently I’m not, and I literally just learned that I’ve been taking anxiety medication without knowing because of those shitty ‘panic attacks’”, he mimicked quotation marks in the air with his good hand.

She nodded comprehensively.

“Your teacher has also told me about that. He said your parents consented to the treatment”.

“Yeah, and they didn’t tell me about it”, Katsuki scoffed, clearly bitter. “I didn’t know anything about it until five minutes ago”.

“And that upsets you”, she affirmed.

“Uh, *yeah*”, Katsuki scoffed, as if it was obvious. “I feel like… Like I was being drugged against my will, with no one telling me about it”.

She nodded again.

“I see. Do you think you would have agreed to the treatment, had you known about it?”

Katsuki thought for a moment.

“I don’t know”, he shrugged. “I can’t – I can’t tell what I would or wouldn’t have done. By choosing for me, they kept me from making that choice for myself. I don’t know what I would have said or done; I wasn’t given that chance. But Aizawa sensei said that even if I had disagreed, I’m a minor. My parents could have consented to the medication on my behalf, even if I didn’t want to take it”.

“Don’t you think they might have wanted to spare you from making that decision? Knowing it would be a tough call for you to make?”

Katsuki scoffed.

“I don’t want to be *spared* of anything. Whatever it is, I can take it. I took this, didn’t I?”, he pointed at his bandaged torso, which was hidden away from view by his hospital gown and his covers.

Doctor Matsuo nodded.

“I don’t think anyone can say that you aren’t strong. But maybe your parents wanted to spare you from yet another difficult decision, after you took so much upon your shoulders. Maybe they didn’t see you as someone who is weak, but as someone who is too strong. Even All Might took day-offs in his prime”.

Katsuki looked away, bitter.

Did you know they are comparing you to All Might? They’re calling you the next All Might, dude. That’s – That’s huge!

“Do you see what I’m saying?”, Doctor Matsuo encouraged, leaning a bit forward. “If even All Might needed to rest –“

“I’m not All Might”, Katsuki huffed, not meeting her eyes. “I’m supposed to be *better* than All Might. I’m supposed to surpass him”.

Doctor Matsuo leaned a bit backwards, reading Katsuki’s face.

“You can still surpass him *and* look after yourself. You’ve told me before that you see your body as a temple. That you take good care of it because you know that you need to be healthy in order to become the best. Isn’t that so?”

Katsuki sighed. But he nodded; she wasn’t lying.

“So don’t you think that taking care of your mental health is also important in your journey to become a pro hero?”

Katsuki sighed, rolling his eyes.

“I *am* taking care of my mental health. I just don’t want to take anxiety meds”, he said.

“Why not?”, Doctor Matsuo inquired curiously.

“Because I don’t have anxiety”, Katsuki met her eyes, hoping she would read the frustration in them. “I don’t need drugs slowing me down and making me sleepy, or dizzy, or making me pass out because of my quirk”.

Doctor Matsuo nodded.

“The medication you were being given does have those as side effects, yes”, she nodded. “I wasn’t consulted when the hospital made the decision to medicate you, but your teacher and the medical staff have talked to me and cleared some points up about your state. They’ve told me how your quirk reacted to the clonazepam”.

Katsuki huffed.

“And what do you think?”, he raised an eyebrow at her.

Doctor Matsuo shifted on her seat. She raised her eyebrows and dropped them just as quickly, facing down before she met his eyes again.

“I don’t think clonazepam is the best medication for you”, she said seriously.

Katsuki relaxed against his pillows and sighed, nodding his head. Finally, someone who was on his fucking side.

“*But* –“, Doctor Matsuo continued. “I do think we can try to find something that suits your quirk and your body better”.

Katsuki scowled at her. Ok. Maybe not *so* on his side.

“I don’t need this shitty medication”, he protested, angry.

“Katsuki –“

“I don’t want to take it! I’ll be of legal age in one year, so if my parents or my doctors or even *you* force me to take it, I’ll just stop doing it once I’m 18”, he added with resentment. She was supposed to back him up. Why was she against him, like everybody else?

Doctor Matsuo raised another calming hand at him.

“No one is going to force you to do anything”, she ensured.

“Everyone already *did*”, Katsuki scoffed. “The only reason they stopped was because that shit started to damage me more than it helped me”.

Doctor Matsuo tilted her head.

“You’re not damaged”, she corrected him. “You’re recovering from a life-threatening injury and yet another traumatic experience”, she pointed out.

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“You love saying I’m traumatized, don’t you?”, he scoffed. He didn’t know why he was so angry at her out of a sudden, but the feeling was there and it was very real.

Doctor Matsuo sighed patiently.

“Katsuki, we’ve talked about this. The things you have witnessed and endured, from the kidnapping to the sewers to the museum, all of that has left a mark on you. That’s not a bad thing, that’s *life*. And I want to tell you something about anxiety. It’s humanity’s most natural instinct. Everyone feels it at some level, at some point. You’re not damaged or sick or weak for feeling it. You’re only human”.

Katsuki glared at her.

“I’m supposed to be better than the average human”, he said through gritted teeth, feeling weaker than ever. He felt like a child who needed to keep reaffirming themselves.

Doctor Matsuo sighed.

“Tell me something, then. Apart from the dizziness and the fainting and the negative side effects you’ve experienced because of the clonazepam. How have you been feeling?”

Katsuki bit his inner cheek. How *had* he been feeling? He was barely awake during the whole time he’s been in the hospital. And when he wasn’t awake, he was talking to Deku. Or texting Deku. Or thinking about Deku. Hell, even when he was asleep, he was dreaming about Deku. What in the goddamn fuck was wrong with him?

“I don’t know”, he said, sincere. “I’ve been sleeping all the time, and when I’m awake, I feel groggy and weak. It’s like I’m not improving at all, like my health keeps deteriorating, and

now I find out that's because of this shit they've been giving me –"

"Ok, all right", Doctor Matsuo raised a calming hand at him. "I understand. You don't want to take clonazepam. You won't be given that anymore, I'll make sure of that", she reassured him.

Katsuki stared at her with a mix of expectation and suspicion. Noticing this, she tilted her head to the side.

"It's like you said, you're almost an adult. Even if we *did* force you to take this, you'd just stop doing it in less than a year from now. It's counterproductive to make you to do this against your will", she explained herself, quirking an eyebrow at him. "And besides that, I'm against it, too. The effects are more negative than they are positive to your body, so my plan is to talk to you so we can work out a different solution".

"A different solution to *what*?", Katsuki narrowed his eyes.

She sighed again.

"Katsuki, do you know what PTSD stands for?", she asked patiently.

He threw his head back, laughing without an ounce of humor in his voice.

"There you go again".

"Tell me what it stands for, please".

He scowled at the ceiling for a few more moments before he glared at her.

"Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder", he said.

She nodded.

"Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder is nothing other than a specific type of anxiety that's triggered by a major event, or a series of major events in a person's life. The trauma caused by these events, or the difficulty to cope with them, triggers anxious episodes, or even panic attacks, that can or can't be accompanied by flashbacks of the traumatic event. Studies show that 85% of pro heroes nowadays suffer or have suffered from PTSD at some point in their careers".

"And I'm gonna be better than 85% of pro heroes", Katsuki pointed out without missing a beat.

"And I don't doubt that", she retorted as quickly. "That's why I'm trying to help you – so you can achieve your greatest potential with nothing to set you back".

He stared at her, face impassive. He didn't know why that statement upset him, but it did. He was grateful that Doctor Matsuo was willing to help him become the greatest hero, but he had hoped she could see him as more than that. From the way she had put it, Katsuki felt as if he

had no use to society unless he was back on his feet and ready to dive deep into heroics again.

But wasn't that what he wanted? To be a hero, and be the greatest? Wasn't that his only worth as a human, the only redeemable aspect of his personality?

With a sigh, she leaned forwards again, supporting her elbows on her thighs.

"I know you were taught you need to be strong all the time. But when you're with me, you don't have to. My literal job is to aid you so you can control your emotions, acknowledge them, and live a healthier life. You say your body is a temple – I'm inclined to agree. But if that metaphor is correct, then your brain is the most important column that sustains that very temple".

Katsuki scoffed. Doctor Matsuo gave him a look.

"I'd rather think of your body as a clock. Does a clock work properly when one of its engines is not aligned with the others?", she tried.

"My brain ain't broken", Katsuki growled.

"I'm not saying it is. Needing help doesn't mean you're broken. Having PTSD doesn't mean you're broken. It only means your brain is tuned into a different radio station than the rest of your body. And my job here is to align your brain to your body, so that it can run in its best capacity".

Katsuki raised an eyebrow.

"I thought your job was to help me deal with my anger".

She nodded.

"And I think I succeeded in that, given the way you saved the day back at that museum".

Katsuki bit his inner cheeks, jaw tight. He wasn't proud of that. He didn't want to talk about that. The way he had managed to save the day still bothered him; the way his anger had been stronger than hundreds of people's love scared him.

Was his capacity to hate really stronger than his capacity to love?

He knew he needed help, or else he wouldn't have called Doctor Matsuo. But what she was offering him – what she was telling him – wasn't what he wanted to hear. He had been hoping for a more conclusive solution than "continuing therapy and taking different meds". He had been hoping for something faster, more decisive. He had been hoping for answers.

Answers. God, he fucking wished he could get some. Especially on the Deku subject. He was so lost, so confused. Had he liked the kiss, the soft lips, the proximity? Was he *supposed* to have liked it? Would he be able to look Deku in the eye the next he saw him, now that he knew what had happened?

“You seem pensive”, Doctor Matsuo commented. “Penny for your thoughts?”

Katsuki gave her a wary look.

Doctor Matsuo smiled encouragingly. This felt like his first session had felt. He was wounded after a major fight with some villains, and she was trying her best to make him open up despite that. At the same time he felt like a different person, he also felt like the same old Katsuki who kept making the same old mistakes.

“Katsuki, I’m only trying to help you”, she told him upon his silence, sensing his hesitation. “We can skip this talk for now, but you can’t run away forever. You’ll need to face it eventually. Remember?”

Avoidance is rarely ever the best option, Katsuki. By facing your problems face-first, you can take them on. By running away from them, you allow them to become bigger than you. Stronger. Until one day, they catch up with you and swallow you whole.

His nostrils flared as he tried to make a decision. He lowered his head.

“I don’t want to take meds”, he admitted decisively. “And I don’t think I have PTSD”.

She opened her mouth to speak, but he kept going.

“*But* I want to continue therapy. With you”, he said, head low. “I saw what the medication did to my body, and I didn’t like it. But you were right about the museum. I did save everyone there because of how you taught me to understand my emotions better”.

She stared at him, silent and attentive.

He looked up at her, eyes piercing.

“Teach me how to control this, too. So that I don’t need to take any meds that screw with my body and my quirk”.

Doctor Matsuo pursed her lips, tilting her chin up.

“Not every medication has the same effect as clonazepam. There are other pills that can help you with the way you’re feeling, without messing with your body or your quirk so aggressively”, she said, pensive. “*But* – in your case, since you’re so resistant, therapy can be a good solution for the time being. Then, we can discuss medication again in the future, in the case you feel like you use some extra help. You don’t have to do anything you don’t want to”.

Katsuki clenched his jaw, nodding at her.

“I can also teach you some breathing exercises”, she announced, waiting for a reaction.

He frowned.

“What?”

“For the case you get stressed out or anxious”, she explained. “They’ll help lower your heartrate and calm you down in a moment of crisis, as in a panic attack or a nightmare”.

Katsuki stared at her.

“I thought that me calming down would be a bad thing. Don’t I need to be constantly stressed out in order not to faint because of my quirk?”

Doctor Matsuo folded her hands together.

“This is a theory that still needs to be looked into more properly”, she explained. “Aizawa-san told me about his and Recovery Girl’s findings, and they are logical. But constant stress isn’t healthy for you, or for anyone. As much as you want to become the best, you still aren’t exempt from the limits of the human body”.

“I’ve been stressed all my life and I’ve been doing just fine”, he pointed out.

Doctor Matsuo raised a disbelieving eyebrow.

“Have you, now?”

“Yeah”, Katsuki nodded with a huff.

Doctor Matsuo leaned forwards.

“What about Midoriya?”

Katsuki felt his heart speed up.

“What about him?”

Doctor Matsuo shrugged.

“He’s been a constant complaint in your sessions with me. You admitted that your temper got in the way of your relationship with him in many instances in the past. Don’t you think things would have been easier if you hadn’t been so stressed around him?”

Katsuki thought about what Doctor Matsuo was saying. He tried to imagine himself, calm and relaxed and full of peace in his heart. He tried to imagine Deku with this version of him. Would he be happier? Would he be more satisfied? Would he be more content if Katsuki was a person who didn’t call him names, didn’t get into arguments with him, didn’t curse like a sailor, didn’t throw his flaws at his face? Would Deku *love* this version of him?

If that was the case, then Katsuki was doomed. Because yes, he was better at controlling his anger now, and he had learned how to use it for good deeds, but he didn’t plan on stopping being a hothead. That was the main reason why taking the meds they wanted to give him scared him so much. They were literal chemical agents that would act on his brain’s metabolism and functionality. They would change his mood, and his behavior, and the way he reacted to things. He sure as fuck didn’t want to have nightmares or flashbacks or that constant, paranoid fear nagging at the back of his mind, turning friends into foes and making

him afraid of his own shadow. But he didn't want to stop being himself, either. That was all he knew how to be.

He couldn't change, not even for Deku. And, for that, maybe he didn't deserve him. Maybe he was just a bully, just a selfish, self-absorbed guy. Deku deserved someone who made him happy, who treated him right. He deserved someone who treated him tenderly, and lovingly, in a way Katsuki didn't know, couldn't know. Deku deserved someone who didn't make him cry, who didn't make him suffer, who didn't tell him to kill himself.

"So?", Doctor Matsuo encouraged him to speak when he didn't reply to her question. "Can we talk about Midoriya?"

Katsuki swallowed dry, eyes fixed on his own feet.

"I kissed him in the mouth", he ended up admitting, because yeah. That had been the main reason why he had called her in.

It felt like a weight had been taken from his shoulders, to reveal that to someone. It also felt like someone had injected him with adrenaline and shocked his heart in to beating thrice as fast.

He didn't dare to look at Doctor Matsuo's face to see her reaction. The woman remained very, very silent, as if absorbing and processing that information. In Katsuki's mind, it took her hours to respond, when in reality she couldn't have taken more than half a minute.

"Do you… want to talk about that?", she asked, sounding suspiciously gleeful. Katsuki turned his head to stare at her.

She was smiling encouragingly from ear to ear. And she didn't look surprised at all.

Katsuki frowned, offended.

"What's that smile for?", he demanded to know. "Why are you giving me that look?"

Doctor Matsuo tilted her head to the side almost pitifully.

"I'm happy for you", she said simply, as if that justified something. If anything, it only made Katsuki even more confused.

"*Why*?", he frowned.

Doctor Matsuo sighed tiredly, patiently.

"Ok, I can see you're still stuck with some pent-up feelings that you haven't figured out quite yet", she commented. "So why don't we focus on that for a bit?"

"I don't have pent-up feelings", Katsuki tried to defend himself.

"Having pent-up feelings is not a bad thing, everyone has them", she justified.

“Stop comparing me to other people”, Katsuki complained, defensive.

“Katsuki, you and I live in a society. Peer comparison is inevitable, and you should know better than anyone”.

“What the hell is that supposed to mean?”

“You’re the one who spent years comparing yourself to All Might. To say you want to be better than him is to put yourself in comparison to him. You compare yourselves, and your desire is to reach a relation of equality, and then surpass that relation of equality and turn it into a relation of superiority, with you above and him beneath”.

Katsuki gritted his teeth, hating that she was right.

“Fine, ok”, he huffed. “But I don’t have *pent-up* feelings. I’m just – I’m completely lost and out of my depth. I don’t know what I’m feeling. And that’s why I called you”, he admitted, feeling naked by the truth. “I remembered the kiss last night. That’s why I freaked out that badly”.

She nodded, indicating that she was listening and that he could continue.

“It happened when he went after me in the wreckage. He was pressing down on my injury. I thought I was going to die. And I just went and kissed him”.

She continued to nod.

“Do you know why you did that?”, she inquired.

Katsuki pursed his lips. He couldn’t tell her about One For All, as much as he wanted to. He couldn’t be completely honest, even if the truth was choking him from the inside out.

But maybe he didn’t have to be honest. Because, deep down, he knew that Deku’s quirk wasn’t the only reason why he had kissed him. Sure, it had been the main motivation, but Katsuki had enjoyed it. He could remember his thoughts with unexpected clarity: *This would probably still feel nice in another situation.*

“I was suffering from blood loss, so I wasn’t thinking straight”, he justified. “But it felt nice. I remember that much. I remember it felt nice, and I…”

She waited patiently for him to elaborate on that.

“I wished I could do it again. On another opportunity”.

She nodded.

“Why don’t you?”, she asked as if things were that simple.

Katsuki squinted.

“What? Are you *serious*?”

“Dead serious”, she nodded without missing a beat.

Katsuki huffed.

“I’m not – I don’t – Deku doesn’t –“, he stuttered, at a loss for words. “I – I – Deku doesn’t *like* boys”, he said that with total certainty.

Doctor Matsuo raised an eyebrow.

“And you know that how…?”

He frowned and shook his head.

“I just *know* it”, he said, completely sure of himself.

Silence.

“Have you ever asked him about it?”

“No!”

“Do *you* like boys?”

Katsuki halted.

“I… I…”, he thought back to his childhood, to his adolescence, to all the boyfriends and girlfriends his classmates had, to the pictures of women in lingerie his colleagues took to school in secret, to the kisses and touches the other students shared.

He thought back to hand-holding scenes during lunchbreak, to the movie posters of buff, thick men that were displayed in panels at the train station. He thought back to his indifference towards girls’ bodies, and his equal indifference towards men’s. He thought back to his lack of arousal towards any gender expression, cis or trans. He thought back to his goal of being the number one hero who surpassed All Might, he thought back to his conclusion of *I can never have a family.*

Could he? Could he not? Because if Deku was a pro hero just like him, maybe they could be together. They could be each other’s family. They could work together and live together and eat together and *why the fuck was Katsuki thinking about starting a family with Deku oh my godddddddd*

“Katsuki?”, Doctor Matsuo encouraged when he did nothing other than blush and glare at his own feet.

“I never thought about this”, he admitted, trying to organize his thoughts in his head. “I never… I mean. I never took interest in any girl. So I thought for a while that maybe I was gay. But then, I didn’t take interest in any boy as well. So I thought, maybe I’m not anything. Gay, or straight, or whatever. Maybe I’m just *me*”.

Doctor Matsuo nodded.

“And I want to be a pro hero, but not just that, I want to be the *best* pro hero there is. And that means I need to work hard and train a lot and spend hours at work and that doesn’t leave much room for having a family or – or taking care of babies or – helping them grow –“

“Who says you need a baby to have a family?”, Doctor Matsuo pointed out.

“Most people”, Katsuki pointed back.

She nodded.

“You’ve got a fair point. Society tends to think of family as a male, a female, and a child. But I’m telling you, it doesn’t necessarily have to be that way”.

“Easy for you to say”, Katsuki huffed. “You fit society’s expectations”.

“Who said that?”, Doctor Matsuo frowned with a smile.

Katsuki blinked. Before he could elaborate, she continued:

“Just because I have a son, it doesn’t mean I have a standard family”, she said shortly. She didn’t seem angry or resentful, just as calm as ever.

Katsuki worried at his lower lip.

“Sorry for making assumptions, I guess”, he ended up saying, feeling a little bit ashamed of himself.

“No problem”, she said gently. “But let’s focus on what *you* said. If you took the baby out of the equation, would you be happy starting a family?”

Katsuki thought for a moment. Him and Deku, together. Like it had always been. Like it was meant to be.

“I don’t know”, he shook his head, afraid of the answer. “I mean, I never even considered it. Having kids, and all that crap. I don’t know if I want that or not”, he said, trying to find excuses. He wouldn’t be able to have a kid, an heir, if he started a life with Deku. Was a *kid* enough of a reason to make this decision?

Doctor Matsuo nodded.

“It’s a big step for anyone. It’s perfectly normal to only think about that when you’re older”.

“Yeah”, Katsuki said. “But I can’t keep delaying *this* until I’m older”.

Doctor Matsuo tilted her head.

“What do you mean?”

“This Deku shit is more urgent”, Katsuki said. “He doesn’t know I remember the kiss, and I only remembered yesterday night. I haven’t seen him since. I don’t know if I’ll be able to talk

to him, knowing I kissed him, and knowing *he* knows I kissed him. I mean – I don't know where to go from here".

Doctor Matsuo gave him a look.

"Why do you presume Midoriya doesn't like boys?", she asked patiently.

Katsuki sighed loudly. Why was she insisting on this? Couldn't she just take his word for it?

"He *doesn't*", he said with irritation. "He just doesn't".

Doctor Matsuo tilted her head.

"Don't you think you might be making a wrong assumption, just like when you assumed that I had a perfect by-the-book family?"

Katsuki squinted as if she was crazy.

"No, he…", he hesitated. "He has the hots for… Round Face", he said, the excuse sounding weird to his own ears.

"Who's that?"

"Uraraka or something", he waved a dismissive hand. "She fought against me in the Sports Festival. She's the girl that makes shit float".

A pause.

"You never mentioned her before", Doctor Matsuo pointed out.

"Yeah, because she's an extra".

"Why do you think Midoriya likes her? Does he talk about her much?"

Katsuki frowned.

"No… Not really", he realized.

Doctor Matsuo nodded, as if she had been expecting that answer.

"But from what you've told me, he seems to talk a lot about *you*".

Katsuki threw his head back.

"That's because he's… He's a stalker nerd. That's it", he convinced himself.

"If he were just a stalker, do you think he would have put up with your hostile attitude towards him for all these years?"

Katsuki looked at her, frowning.

“What are you *saying*?”, he asked.

Doctor Matsuo sighed.

“Let me ask you something. Did you know that most people don’t fall in love?”, she asked calmly.

Katsuki frowned.

“What?”

She crossed her legs and rested her hands on her knees.

“Most people *walk* into love. In other words, the process of loving someone in the romantic sense is usually very slow. It doesn’t happen overnight. In some cultures, it takes years for it to happen. Take arranged marriages, for example”.

Katsuki squinted, but he didn’t say anything. He didn’t even know why they were talking about this in the first place.

“The Ancient Greek had seven words to describe love”, Doctor Matsuo continued. “Have you ever heard about this?”

Katsuki shook his head. She nodded at him.

“First, we have Eros, which is romantic, sexual love. Then, there’s Philia, which is authentic friendship; Ludus, which is playful, flirtatious love; Storge, which is the unconditional love you feel for your family; Philautia, which is self-love; Pragma, which is enduring, companionate love; and Agape, which is empathetic, altruistic love”.

“O… k…?”, he said, still squinting and not really getting her point.

“I’m telling you all this because you don’t need to *know* what love is”, she said emphatically.

“Yeah, except you just went and told me about the seven types of love anyway”, he ironized.

She smiled.

“Yes. Do any of them ring any bells?”

Katsuki thought for a moment. Then, he blushed.

“I… Um. I don’t know if I should tell you this. I mean, I’ve already told you a lot of personal shit that’s embarrassing, but this… I’m not sure. If I should tell you. Maybe it’s too personal”.

“Tell me what?”, she asked patiently.

He looked away, not daring to meet her eyes.

“It’s about… uh, the Eros one. I had a… very male-like… *bodily reaction* to one dream, the other day”.

She nodded comprehensively.

“Did the dream involve Midoriya?”

Katsuki hesitated; then, he nodded silently.

“I see”, she said. “So you think that what you feel for him is desire?”

Katsuki snapped his head to give her an offended look.

“What? *No*!”

“Katsuki”, she smiled, amused. “This is all *perfectly normal*. You’re a teenager, your body is flooding with hormones –“

“Yeah, but I’m not that person!”, he protested. “Hormones or not – I mean – I never even thought about sex until this shit! Sure, the thought crossed my mind a few times and I looked into it, but I never felt the want – the *need* – the – the –“

“Ok, let’s take a step back”, she instructed calmly. “This is all very new for you, so it’s normal to feel confused. Tell me what you think Midoriya feels for you”.

Katsuki leaned back against his pillows, pensive.

“He… I used to think he looked down on me”.

“Yes”, she nodded encouragingly.

“But now I know he admired me”, Katsuki swallowed dry. “And he cares for me. He worries about me. I wish he didn’t, because I’m not some weak little thing, but he does it anyway. I can’t stop him”, he shrugged.

“Yes”, she nodded. “And what do *you* feel for him?”

Katsuki worried at his lower lip.

“The same”, he shrugged again. “I care about him and I worry about him. Sometimes, way too much. I pushed him away all these years because – because I was afraid of him. He made me realize things about myself that got under my skin. He… He made me insecure”.

Doctor Matsuo nodded.

“You said you considered the possibility you were gay for a while. But other boys didn’t make you feel attraction”.

“Yeah”.

“But Midoriya *did* make you feel attraction, since your body reacted like you said it did”.

Katsuki sighed heavily.

“It’s not… *that*”.

There was a pause.

“Then what is it?”, Doctor Matsuo asked.

Katsuki ran his good hand across his hair, staring up at the ceiling.

“I don’t know”, he shrugged helplessly, his good hand resting above his healing injury. “I just don’t know”.

Doctor Matsuo nodded.

“It’s normal to feel confused, Katsuki. It’s your first time going through this”.

“Going through *what*? I don’t even know what *this* is!”

Doctor Matsuo offered him a patient smile.

“Let me try to put this in other way, then. Why don’t you and I go over the seven loves and try to see what we can take from them?”

Katsuki scoffed, glaring at the wall. Doctor Matsuo stared at him comprehensively.

“If you want to, we can leave this talk for another day”, she suggested. “If you’re tired –“

“No”, Katsuki interrupted her. Deku would probably visit him soon, and Katsuki wanted to be able to look him in the eye. “I want to do this”.

She nodded.

“So, Eros”, she started. “Do you think you feel that for him? Remember that Eros has to do with desire, lust, physical sensations”.

Katsuki blinked.

“I don’t know, maybe”, he shrugged. “I mean, I had the boner – uh, the… *erection*…”

“It’s all right, you can say boner”, Doctor Matsuo reassured him.

Katsuki bit his lower lip.

“I had the boner because of the kiss. Or rather, the dream about the kiss”.

She nodded.

“What about Philia?”

“What was that one again?”

“Intimate, authentic friendship”, she clarified.

Katsuki huffed a little laugh through his nose.

“I don’t know if I can call what he had a *friendship*”, he admitted. “At least not for most of our lives”.

“But he still gets described by others as your childhood friend”, she pointed out.

Katsuki shrugged.

“Yeah”.

“And you said so yourself, that you’re friends with him, now”.

He nodded silently.

“So we can put a little check beside that one, too, right?”

Katsuki shrugged, a bit begrudged.

“And Ludus?”

“I don’t remember what that one was”.

“Playful, flirtatious love”.

He laughed.

“Deku doesn’t know how to flirt”, he said mockingly.

“Do you?”, Doctor Matsuo raised her eyebrow.

The laughter died on his lips and Katsuki glared at her.

“I’m just saying”, she defended herself upon his vicious look, raising her hands in surrender. “But from what you told me so far, you seem to like teasing each other”.

He thought for a moment.

“I like teasing him, but he’s shit at understanding it”, Katsuki pointed out. “He always thinks I’m serious when I’m not, and when I’m actually being serious, he doesn’t listen to me”.

Doctor Matsuo tilted her head.

“But you do like the teasing, then”, she concluded.

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“Yeah”.

“So… check?”

Katsuki sighed. There was no winning with her, was there?

“Check”.

“What about Storge?”

“Is that the family one?”

“Yes”.

“Then no”.

“Why not?”

“Because he’s not my family”.

“A husband is a part of a family”.

Katsuki chocked on thin air.

“*Husband?!*”, he grew red in the face at the thought of Deku as his bride. Or would *he* be the bride? Two grooms?!?!

Doctor Matsuo raised both her hands in surrender.

“I’m just hypothesizing”, she defended herself.

“No. No check on that one”, Katsuki said, riled up by that idea.

She nodded.

“Philautia doesn’t really help the case I’m trying to make, but I’m sure you and him both have plenty of it”.

“Is it the self-love?”, Katsuki inquired.

“Yes”.

“He doesn’t have it”, Katsuki disagreed. “The idiot never thinks about his own wellbeing. He’s constantly breaking his bones and throwing himself into danger for the sake of other people”.

“I’ll get to that in a minute”, she promised. “First, tell me about Pragma”.

Katsuki squinted.

“I don’t remember that one, either”.

“It’s enduring, companionate love”, Doctor Matsuo explained. “It’s a love that’s built on commitment, on accepting differences and learning how to compromise. I’m not picking sides here, but from what I’ve accompanied during our sessions, you seemed to be learning to compromise pretty well, especially in your relationship with Midoriya”.

Katsuki thought back to the whole museum saga; to the way he had accepted Deku’s demand to accompany them and help despite Katsuki’s worry about his state.

“Fine. Check”, he said, eyes downcast. It was becoming more and more difficult to look into Doctor Matsuo’s eyes.

“That leaves us the last one, Agape”, she said. “Which I believe is the type of love both you and Midoriya share the most”.

Katsuki looked at her, looking like an animal that had been cornered by a hunter. The looked lasted for a moment; then, he lowered his gaze again.

“Midoriya laid his life down for your sake”, she explained, eyes fixed on Katsuki. “Both in the Sludge Villain incident, and in the Soulmonger incident. I believe I wouldn’t be so wrong in saying that you would also be willing to lay down your life for his sake, if the need arose”, she completed.

Katsuki swallowed dry, averting his eyes from her. He ran the back of his hand against his nose, sniffing.

“Yeah”, he said simply.

There was silence.

“Do you understand the point I’m trying to make?”, she asked patiently.

Katsuki kept his head low, his eyes moving without focusing on anything in particular. He tracked the wrinkles on the sheet covering his legs, noticing the patterns of the fabric and the shadows it created. He counted his breaths, one, two, three. Four, five, six. Seven, eight, nine. Ten.

“Katsuki?”, she asked softly.

“I do”, he said. He bit his lower lip.

She waited patiently.

“What is it?”, she nudged.

Katsuki threw his head back again, staring at the ceiling. The sunset was painting it orange.

“I love Deku”, he said, and the words flowed out of him easily, naturally, as if they were meant to be. There was something sempiternal about them. “In many ways, I love him”, he shrugged.

She nodded.

“Do you know for how long?”

Katsuki continued to stare at the reflection of the window’s glass on the ceiling and the walls.

“I… don’t know”, he admitted after a few moments of silence.

Doctor Matsuo nodded again.

“And how does that make you feel?”, she asked calmly.

Katsuki closed his eyes.

“Afraid”, he admitted, shameless about that feeling for the first time in his life.

Doctor Matsuo nodded.

“That’s perfectly natural”.

That angered him.

“No, it’s *not*. I’m not supposed to be scared of *anything*”, he spat, and then he immediately felt like a child, like a little boy who was trying to pretend he was older and braver than he actually was.

“Everyone gets scared of things they don’t know”, she said. “But once you get familiarized and understand it better, the fear goes away”.

Katsuki scowled, reopening his eyes to glare at her.

“So that’s your suggestion? Get familiarized with Deku? Try to understand him?”, he huffed. “I know the bastard like I know my own *quirk*. There’s nothing new to me when it comes to him”.

Doctor Matsuo sighed softly.

“You’re not afraid of him, Katsuki”.

Katsuki felt his eyes sting. He sniffed again. If anyone else had told him that, he would have exploded with a *don’t tell me what I am feeling!!*, but since this was Doctor Matsuo, all he felt was a painful desire to make her understand.

“I’ve *always* been afraid of him”, he admitted, voice hoarse. “He was nothing but this weak, scrawny kid who trailed after me, and yet he always acted as if he was so much better. And the worst part was that he was right. He stood up for the other kids. He worried about other people. He – He’s always been more of a hero than me, even if he didn’t have –”.

A quirk, Katsuki completed in his mind. But he couldn’t reveal Deku’s secret, so he stayed silent.

Doctor Matsuo raised her eyebrows at that confession.

“You don’t usually say that about anyone”, she commented.

“That’s why I forced myself to hate him”, Katsuki sniffed again, rubbing the back of his hand against his eyes to keep his tears from flowing. “Out of the whole wide world, he was the only thing that scared me”.

“But you don’t hate him anymore”, Doctor Matsuo pointed out. “Don’t you think that’s because you got to know him a little better?”

Katsuki rubbed his hand on his face.

“I did get to know him better”, he placed his good hand behind his head. “And a lot of shit that bothered me, that didn’t make sense at first… It all became a bit clearer. But now I’m back at being scared and I don’t know what to *do*”, his voice broke at the last words. “It feels like I’ve gone all the way back to before that villain attacked us”.

Doctor Matsuo nodded.

“So you believe your love is unrequited?”, she asked.

Katsuki swallowed dry, glaring at the ceiling. He felt like he was floating in the middle of the ocean, without sand on the bottom for him to step on. He could sink and drown in a sea of nothingness in any minute. Only his head was above the water level.

And despite everything you did to me… I still love you, Kacchan. I always have.

So far, he hadn’t taken those words to the heart. If anything, he had gone out of his way to pretend he hadn’t heard them. But now? Now he couldn’t keep denying it. He couldn’t keep pretending Deku hadn’t said them to him, loud and clear, clear as a day.

Deku loved him, and there was nothing Katsuki could do about it.

“He doesn’t love me”, he shook his head, decisive. “He loves the image of me he created in his head”.

He sounded like he was trying to convince himself, rather than Doctor Matsuo.

She clicked her tongue.

“And what would that idea be?”

You are my image of victory. That’s why I know I won’t die.

“His *image of victory*”, he scoffed, mocking. “His ideal of a hero. I’m not the person he wishes I was. I’m not – I’m not enough for him”.

Doctor Matsuo seemed surprised.

“That sounds awfully self-deprecating, coming from someone as confident as you”.

“That’s because it’s him, right?”, Katsuki shook his head, looking at her. “He’s the one who does this to me. I’m never weak, until he shows up with a strong ass quirk. I never lose, until it’s his life at stake. I’m never insecure, until he comes around. It’s like he knows all the ways around my defenses. It’s like – it’s like – I’m swiped off my feet when he shows up. Because I feel like I deserve the world, unless he’s in the equation. How could someone like *me* make him happy?”

Doctor Matsuo frowned.

“What do you mean?”

“All I do is hurt him”, Katsuki rubbed his eyes again, hating his tears, wishing to get rid of them. “All I’ve *ever* done is hurt him. Even when I try not to. Even when I’m trying to keep him safe. Why would he love someone who only brings him pain?”

Doctor Matsuo nodded comprehensively.

“I can’t speak for Midoriya”, she said. “I can’t tell you his reasons or his feelings. But, from what you told me, he was very forgiving of your past behavior. And your relationship with him improved a lot, when the two of you were stuck together”.

Katsuki nodded.

“He got me. He used to get me”, he shrugged. “It made things easy”.

“And they can stay easy”, she said. “Love doesn’t have to be hard”.

Katsuki deflated, shaking his head again.

“*Nothing* with him is easy”.

“In that case, it’s a good thing you love to be challenged”, she smiled.

Katsuki looked at her. She was being so light, so optimistic about this, that he couldn’t help but to feel a twinge of hope squeeze his heart.

“What… are you saying?”, he asked, helpless.

“I’m saying you’re no coward. That much has been clear to me ever since our first session”, she said. “And I’m *also* saying you never back down from a challenge. You never lower your head for anyone. You never cower from anything. So why is Midoriya the only exception?”

Katsuki frowned and swallowed dry, blinking in confusion.

“I… I don’t know”, he admitted. “He’s always been the exception”.

She nodded.

“You’re not afraid of him”, she repeated, calmly. “You’ve never been afraid of him. You’re afraid of what he makes you *feel*”.

Katsuki looked at her.

“He was the only one who made you feel new things. Things that weren’t the anger or the self-entitlement you were so accustomed with. Vulnerability, at first, and now, love. In fact, there is no true love without some level of vulnerability. But trust makes up for that. And that’s *fine*. What you’re feeling is fine. Like I said, we fear things we don’t understand. And I think Midoriya has been the biggest question mark in your life, so far”.

Katsuki swallowed. He thought back to that small quirkless kid who followed him around and showered him in praise. He thought back to the way Deku used to idolize him, and to the way he was led to believe that Deku was worthless to society because he didn’t have a quirk. He thought back to his confusion when Deku stood up to others but never to himself, to the way he acted hero-like even though he was born without a gift. He thought back to their fights, to their talks, to their cuddling, to their kiss.

He wanted more of that. He didn’t know why, but he was addicted to Deku, like he had actually become a part of his soul.

And hadn’t he? His quirk and the vestige of his literal soul lived within Katsuki now, the same way Katsuki’s lived within Deku. They were connected. Bounded. For life. What they had gone through had changed them, scarred them, branded them. They had left a bit of themselves inside the other.

But what did Katsuki *want*? A family? A relationship? He didn’t really know. He never thought about that. All his life, his only goal had been to become a hero – the number one hero. He had never thought past that. He had never allowed himself to have other wants, other needs. He had never allowed himself to be anything other than a pro hero, he had never allowed himself to be just a boy, just a human, with humanly desires.

He thought back to Deku outstretching that little hand to him in the river.

While everyone saw Katsuki as a potential hero, while Katsuki only ever saw the worth in himself be associated to his potential as a hero… Deku had seen him as a kid. A child, a person. The boy with no quirk. The boy Katsuki bullied.

Life without Deku was unimaginable to him. He knew that much, now, after all the terrible things they went through. But life *with* Deku wasn’t enough for him. Katsuki wanted more. He couldn’t be satisfied with just Deku’s rivalry or admiration or praise. He wanted more. *More*. *More, please, more.*

You are my image of victory. That’s why I know I won’t die. And despite everything you did to me… I still love you, Kacchan. I always have.

Katsuki felt his face scrunch up. He compulsively rubbed his hand on his eyes, sniffing louder and louder.

Deku loved him, and there was nothing Katsuki could do about it.

The room was silent apart from the tiny noises Katsuki was making.

“Do you want to tell me why you’re crying?”, Doctor Matsuo asked empathically after a while.

Katsuki snorted and shook his head.

“I don’t want to lose him”, he admitted, feeling vulnerable, and weak, and so, so lost. The only reason he didn’t feel embarrassed or mortified by his current behavior was the knowledge that Doctor Matsuo was bound by doctor-patient confidentiality. She couldn’t tell anyone about this, about his breakdown, about his weakness.

“Why would you lose him?”, she asked patiently, unshaken by the sight of him coming undone.

“I don’t know”, Katsuki shook his head. “If I tell him about the kiss – I don’t know how he’ll react, if he’ll push me away –“

“You don’t remember how he reacted then?”, she inquired.

“No, I passed out”, Katsuki swallowed past the knot in his throat. “And *fuck*, I hate feeling like this. I hate that he does this to me, I hate it, I *hate it*”, he grunted through gritted teeth, voice hoarse. He was becoming angry. “I’m not supposed to be some weak little shit who cries over a *kiss*, what am I, a twelve-year-old? But I can’t, he makes me so confused, I can’t think, I just – I just want things to be ok between us”, he admitted. “For once in my *goddamn* life, I want to be close to him”.

Doctor Matsuo nodded.

“Ok, Katsuki, try to take deep breaths”, she instructed calmly. “You’re still recovering, ok? You can’t strain yourself too much. If you’re not feeling well, I can end our session here so you can rest”.

Katsuki scoffed in between breaths and glared at her.

“Well, this is your fucking fault!”, he snapped. “You’re the one who made me realize this shit”.

“Yes, I know”, she nodded patiently. “But this would happen eventually, whether or not I had intervened. We can still talk about this and figure it out, ok?”

Katsuki squeezed his eyes shut.

“I just want – I just want –“, he struggled to get the words out.

“What is it?”, she urged.

Deku loved him, and there was nothing Katsuki could do about it.

“I just – I want to *be* with him. But I don’t know if he wants that”, he admitted, jaw locked.

Doctor Matsuo took a deep breath.

“Again, I don’t know Midoriya, so I can’t speak for him”, she said. “But, from what you’ve told me, he seems to care for you very much. To the point where he was willing to die for you”.

“And all I did in return was *hurt* him”, Katsuki scowled.

“He never seemed to care much about that”, Matsuo said. “Otherwise, he wouldn’t have followed you for all those years. I’m not saying it’s ok for you to hurt him, or that it’s ok for him to not care about it. I’m just stating a fact. What really matters is this: do you *still* want to hurt him?”

“*No*”, Katsuki said without missing a beat. “But I end up doing that anyway”.

“What do you mean by that?”

Katsuki took a shaky breath.

“He told me”, he swallowed past the knot in his throat. “He said that his soul was attached to the villain’s. When I blew the guy up back in that sewer gallery, he felt *everything*. He was stuck for days with his soul burning in a hellfire *I* caused. He suffered because of *me*, because of what I did”.

Doctor Matsuo seemed a bit surprised. She was silent for a few moments.

“I’m… sorry to hear that”, she said eventually. “That’s really a terrible situation. But… did he blame you?”

“*No*”, Katsuki huffed, angry. “That’s what pisses me off the most. I do all this shit, and he never blames me for it. He never goes away. He’s always after me, calling me *Kacchan* and acting like I’m the best thing he’s ever seen”.

Doctor Matsuo gave him a patient look.

“Don’t you think that means something?”, she asked.

Katsuki shook his head and rubbed his eyes again.

“Yeah, it means that he’s a fucking idiot”, he barked.

Doctor Matsuo sighed.

“Katsuki…”, she said tiredly.

He looked at her, eyes red-rimmed and wet. She smiled softly at him.

“You were already honest about your feelings”, she said. “Don’t you think it’s time to be honest with Midoriya, too?”

Katsuki scoffed.

“What, you’re saying I should go to him and tell him I love him?”

She nodded vehemently. Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“And when he decides he’ll never look me in the eye again and I lose him for good? What then?”

“You just said it yourself that he never goes away when it comes to you”.

“Yeah, but that was *before* the soulbond shit”, Katsuki pointed out. “He stopped talking to me for *six months* after that. I can’t –“, he rubbed his face. “I can’t go through that again”.

“He didn’t have his memories when he stopped talking to you”, she pointed out. “Is he still amnesiac?”

Katsuki looked at her with something hidden in his crimson eyes. It looked familiarly like hope.

“No”, he admitted. “He… He remembered”.

“Everything?”

He swallowed.

“Everything”.

She nodded.

“Why do you think he hasn’t discussed the kiss with you yet?”

Katsuki blinked, thinking for a while.

“I don’t know”, he shrugged. “He probably didn’t want to make things awkward”.

She nodded.

“So maybe he feels as you do. Maybe he’s afraid to talk about this subject and ruin the relationship you have. You never told me how you two went back to talking after all those months”.

“It was at the museum”, Katsuki explain. “The idiot was captured by the villains and I found him by accident. We had to work together on a plan to save everyone, so we started talking to each other again. We argued a lot in the meantime, because I wanted him to escape with your son and he didn’t want to go. So I let him go with me and we were captured”.

Doctor Matsuo nodded.

“So you reconciled during a moment of emergency”, she concluded. “And now he’s been visiting you and talking to you properly, even though the emergency is over?”

“He’s written a notebook”, Katsuki said. “With a lot of shit that he wants to say to me. Conclusions about his time as a ghost, and all sorts of small details about our relationship that he wants to clarify. Aizawa sensei kept him from visiting me while I was in the hospital, so he took that time to write a journal or some shit”.

Doctor Matsuo nodded.

“He seems determined to getting your friendship back to good terms, if he went through the trouble of writing a whole notebook on it”, she commented.

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“He writes notebooks about *everything*, that’s not breaking news”, he retorted.

“It’s still an admirable effort”, she pointed out. “Do you think he would have done that if he didn’t want to stay close to you, with or without the kiss?”

Katsuki frowned at her.

“What?”

She shrugged.

“All I’m saying is that if he had been so bothered because you kissed him, he could have started to distance himself from you as soon as possible. In that scenario, he wouldn’t have needed to visit you or to talk to you”.

Katsuki swallowed dry. Yeah, Deku still visited him despite of the kiss. And he seemed to be trying hard to sort the remaining beef between them so that they could be in better terms. But he hadn’t been willing to *discuss* the kiss, though. Whenever Katsuki demanded to know how he had gotten One For All back, he changed the subject or downright refused to respond, which told Katsuki that yeah, he really didn’t want to talk about that subject.

But Doctor Matsuo was right, Katsuki wasn’t a coward. He needed to talk about that. Whether Deku wanted to or not.

“Katsuki”, Doctor Matsuo called his attention again, sounding very patient but very strict. “You and Midoriya have been through too much together. After everything you did to him, whether you had the intention to hurt him or not, I don’t think he’s going to back away from you because of a single kiss. If he really *does* reject your feelings, which I don’t think probable, you can always claim that you were out of your mind from blood loss when you did what you did and that you didn’t mean it that way. It’s a lie, but it’s better than repressing your feelings and suffering like you’re suffering now”.

Katsuki sniffed, looking offended.

“I’m not *suffering*”, he said, but the defensive statement sounded half-hearted to his own ears.

“Yes, you are, darling”, she said affectionately, her tone heavy with sympathy. “And I don’t want to see you suffer. My job is to help you through things like this. Repressing your feelings does more harm than good, I thought you would know that by now”.

Katsuki stared at her. She offered him a tiny smile.

“I think we should call it a day”, she announced, standing up from the visitor’s chair. “We’ve talked about a lot today and you need to rest in order to get better. You also need to think about everything we’ve discussed. I’ll come back to another session with you in a few days, alright?”

Katsuki blinked. So much time had passed, and he didn’t even notice it. Had he said everything he wanted to say? Was this it?

“Wait, doc”, he called after her from the bed. “I – I mean, what about the meds? The clonazepam?”

“I’ll tell Recovery Girl it’s my professional opinion that they should stop giving it to you”, she reassured him. “But you should know that they can’t cut it off completely overnight, or else you’d go cold turkey. They’ll give you smaller and smaller doses until your body gets used to the drug’s absence”.

Katsuki frowned, but he nodded. He didn’t really like the idea of continuing getting drugged with that shit, but he trusted Doctor Matsuo. He was thankful she was on his side on this, and that she would speak on his behalf. The thing about going cold turkey made sense – he didn’t want to have shitty abstinence symptoms that would make him seem even weaker.

“Will you tell them I don’t want any other anxiety meds?”, he asked.

She pursed her lips.

“I will talk to them about this possibility, yes”, she nodded. “But don’t worry about that just now. You won’t take anything you don’t consent to; I’ll make sure of that. And like I said, we can talk about this again in the future, explore other options”.

Katsuki nodded.

“Try to get some sleep”, she said. “And feel free to text or call me if you need anything. I’ll be available for you 24/7”.

Katsuki narrowed his eyes.

“I thought you had said you wouldn’t show any favoritism”.

She winked at him.

“I won’t tell if you don’t”.

Katsuki huffed out a small laugh through his nose.

“Before I go”, she said, stopping by the door. “I wanted to tell you one last thing”.

Katsuki stared at her.

“What is it?”

She took a deep breath.

“Don’t feel afraid to talk to Midoriya”, she advised. “My bet is that he’s as confused as you. So do what you always do. Raise your chin, gather your courage, and face your fear in the face. Even if you’re terrified inside, don’t show it. Remember about Pragma – to love *despite*, rather than to love because. And also, remember this: a hedgehog’s spine only hurts others when it’s afraid”.

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“You and your stupid hedgehogs”.

She smiled as she opened the door and left the room.

Katsuki stared at the door closing behind her, and then he let his thoughts wander as he turned back to the now empty visitor’s chair. He found himself wishing Deku was there with him.

He did feel tired, though. Learning about the drugs and talking about his emotions had taken a huge emotional toll, and his body wasn’t quite strong enough to deal with it just yet. Before he knew better, he had fallen asleep – whether it was because of the effects of the clonazepam or due to actual fatigue, he couldn’t tell.

He woke up later to an empty, dark room.

With a sigh, Katsuki rubbed his eyes and looked around. His phone was lying on the nightstand, and he turned on his side in order to reach for it. His stitches were pulled when he moved, and he hissed a bit in discomfort, but once he grabbed the phone, he lied back on his back and let out a breath he didn’t realize he had been holding.

There were several texts from his friends, which was starting to bother him a bit, but he noticed three new ones from Deku. He opened the chat.

From: Deku

How are you?

From: Deku

I stopped by, but they didn’t let me in

From: Deku

Just send me some news when you can, ok? I'm worried.

Katsuki sighed. He didn't know what they had told Deku, but of course the nerd would get worried. Katsuki tried really hard not to be offended by that, because now he knew this was just Deku being Deku.

From: Kacchan

What do you know?

It took Deku a while to reply. Katsuki was nearly dozing off with his phone in hands when it pinged with a new message.

From: Deku

Aizawa sensei told me the basics. How are you faring up?

Katsuki thought about what to say. He supposed he should keep acting normally when talking to Deku, even after dreaming about the kiss. The nerd wouldn't know if he didn't say anything, right? He was clearly trying to stay friends with Katsuki. He was trying to be close to him. And Katsuki knew Deku knew about the kiss – that much was evident. If Katsuki never mentioned he remembered, Deku would never have a reason to go away.

From: Kacchan

I'm fine

From: Kacchan

Don't wanna talk about it

From: Deku

Ok

From: Deku

What do you want to talk about?

Katsuki scoffed. He shouldn't say anything. He knew he really shouldn't. But that subject – that memory – was nagging slowly at his brain, consuming his every thought and clouding his attention for all other things. Doctor Matsuo had told him to be brave and face this, she had insisted he shouldn't be afraid. And she had never wronged him or given him ill advice. He knew he could trust her.

Still, his heart was beating fast inside his chest. He never felt so anxious, not even when facing the strongest of enemies. So why did Deku made him feel like that? Why was it always Deku, always messing with his head?

Ok, you know what? Fuck it.

From: Kacchan

How do you have your quirk back?

The reply took a while to come.

From: Deku

I'm not discussing this over text

From: Kacchan

Why not?

From: Deku

It's dangerous

From: Kacchan

To whom?

From: Deku

You know, Kacchan

From: Deku

Let’s talk about something else

From: Deku

Have you been talking to your friends? How are they?

Katsuki couldn’t help but to feel a little resented. He had ignored his fear and tried to talk to Deku about this shit that scared him so much, but the nerd continued being pretty much of a spineless coward. Had he hated the kiss? Was that why he was avoiding this subject like a plague?

Had he *liked* the kiss? Was that why he didn’t want to talk about it?

God, he was driving Katsuki insane. He needed a break. He needed to rest. He wouldn’t be getting much from this conversation, that much was evident to him.

From: Kacchan

You know what? I’m going to sleep

From: Deku

Ok

From: Deku

Are you really ok?

From: Kacchan

Yes Deku

From: Kacchan

Stop motherhenning me

From: Deku

All right

Katsuki blocked the screen of his phone and set the device beneath his pillow, rather than on the nightstand. He tried his best not to think about Deku or the kiss as he went back to sleep, but he knew this was a meaningless effort.

He, of course, failed.

The next day, Deku visited him. He seemed as normal as he had been on the previous days of the week – as if the kiss Katsuki had remembered had never even happened, as if everything was fine between them.

Everything was *not* fine.

“Hi”, Deku greeted with a tight smile.

“Hi”, Katsuki replied a bit grumpily, still resented from the night before.

Silence.

“So… how are you?”, Deku asked, sensing Katsuki wasn’t in the best of moods just from the look on his face.

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“Same I told you yesterday”, he said. “I’m fine”.

His face was impassive, revealing nothing to Deku’s searching eyes. Deku sighed, discontent.

“I thought we had agreed we’d be more honest with each other”.

Katsuki suppressed a scowl.

“We never agreed on that”, he pointed out.

A pause. Deku nodded.

“I was hoping we could”, he corrected himself.

Silence.

There were many things Katsuki wanted to say, but didn’t know how to.

“I know you must be upset”, Deku continued. “But now that everyone knows what’s wrong –“

“I told you I don’t want to talk about it”, Katsuki cut him off. Of the many things he was dying to discuss, his current situation with his meds wasn’t a priority on his list. All he could think of – all he could focus on – was the goddamn kiss and nothing else.

Deku lowered his head. There was a serious look on his face.

“I think we should talk about it”, he insisted.

“Deku…”, Katsuki started, half-tired, half-angry.

“Don’t you trust me?”, Deku demanded, sounding raw and honest.

Katsuki stared at him. He was pissed, but he didn’t want to get into yet another argument. Plus, they had already gone through this. It surprised him that Deku didn’t know the answer to that question.

“I do”, he said, sincere.

“Then be *honest* with me”, Deku demanded, and yeah, Katsuki wasn’t going there.

“I could tell you the same”, he accused. *How can you demand honesty from me when you won’t even go near the kiss subject?*

A sigh.

“Kacchan…”, it was Deku’s turn to try tiredly.

Katsuki swallowed dry. This was it. Now or never. Be brave, be strong, raise your chin, face your foes.

“Tell me how you got your quirk back”, he demanded. His heart was beating hard and fast inside his ribcage.

Deku pursed his lips and looked away, seeming troubled.

“I don’t want to”, he admitted, and Katsuki’s heart skipped a beat.

Not “I can’t”. Deku had said he didn’t want to. He didn’t *want* to.

Katsuki felt his chest tighten and his heart beat faster. His hands were sweating, a bit numb. He was so nervous and desolated he couldn’t even feel his face, because Deku… Deku was about to reject him, right? He hadn’t enjoyed the kiss and he *didn’t* want to discuss this; he didn’t want to go anywhere near that subject… And that could only mean something bad.

His courage was faltering. His heart, the stupid little thing, was begging him to back up and change into a subject that made Deku feel more comfortable – a subject that wouldn’t make him turn his back, leave, and never return. Katsuki didn’t want to lose him. Katsuki *couldn’t* lose him. Not after everything, not after… after *walking into love.*

He hadn't fallen in love. It hadn't been rushed, or sudden. It had been a stroll, a fieldtrip, a lifetime of wandering the dark with only the light of green eyes shining upon him, from the very first day, until he found himself unable to keep soft green curls and starlike freckles out of his damn mind.

Fuck, he had it bad. He had it *so* bad. It didn't feel fair that Deku would dismiss him like this, when Katsuki felt like he did. And yes, he knew, he had been an asshole in the past, and thus Deku didn't owe him anything, any answers, especially in regards of why he didn't love Katsuki back. But still… It felt unfair.

"Why not?", Katsuki found himself asking, heartbroken.

Deku hesitated. He was avoiding Katsuki's eyes like the plague, staring at his own feet instead. Katsuki noticed his hands were trembling, as well as the rest of his body.

Was he angry? Was he holding back tears? What was going on? How could Katsuki make this better?

"I'm… Afraid to", Deku said, voice small and constricted.

Katsuki had to be honest: he wasn't expecting this. He had been half-preparing himself to be dismissed, or to receive a straight refusal.

"What? *Afraid*?", Katsuki asked, confused. "Why?"

Deku stepped away from the bed, hands fiddling with the hem of his shirt. He hadn't brought his notebook with him today, Katsuki noticed. As if he had run out of subjects to discuss. He took a deep breath, and continued with a tight voice:

"I'm afraid you're going to hate me if I tell you", he said, sincere.

Katsuki blinked up at him.

He tried to understand Deku's perspective. Yeah, he had hated him in the past. But that had been because he didn't understand Deku. Like Doctor Matsuo had said, he was the one big question mark in Katsuki's life. It was logical that Deku felt like Katsuki could go back to hating him, after so many years of keeping him at arm's length.

But… Deku wasn't saying he was afraid Katsuki hated him. Deku was saying he was afraid Katsuki hated him because of the *kiss.* Which didn't make any sense, because the kiss hadn't been his fault. Katsuki had been the one who made the first move. Katsuki had been the one to shove his tongue into Deku's mouth; if anyone was to blame, it was him. What the hell was Deku afraid of, then?

"I think we're back to sharing feelings", Deku said when Katsuki didn't respond, and yeah, that phrase sucker-punched Katsuki away from his thoughts about the kiss.

Deku was still keeping his head low, hands fiddling with his shirt and shaking like he was about to cry. Katsuki never took his eyes off him, but they became unfocused as he thought about what he had just heard. He and Deku, sharing feelings? Again? How come?

If Katsuki had to make an analysis of his feelings for the past weeks, he wouldn't be able to. He'd been asleep for most of the time, and, whenever he was awake, he felt too groggy or too tired to concentrate on something as stupid as feelings.

The only exception to that, however, had been Deku. When he was with Deku, he felt balanced. He felt normal. He felt like himself. He didn't know what was it about the nerd that seemed to stabilize him when doctors, nurses, teachers and psychologists failed. Talking to Doctor Matsuo had been enlightening, sure, but Katsuki had been so stressed and exhausted afterwards.

Was Deku causing him stress when he visited? Was that why Katsuki felt normal, because Deku made him stressed to the point his increased heartbeat made up for the decrease caused by the nitroglycerin poisoning?

No, it wasn't only that. Deku was shaking, and fidgety, and nervous. He was probably under a lot of stress because Katsuki kept insisting on talking about the kiss. Katsuki, on the hand, was feeling pretty normal. Not groggy, not sleepy, not weak, not tired. He felt like he could stand up and go back to his room at the dorms, and he wouldn't feel dizzy or fall on his face.

Maybe Deku was the one who was stressed. And, by sharing that emotion with Katsuki, who was currently sedated by the clonazepam, through the remains of the bond that connected them, he turned his decreased heartrate into a normal one. Deku's stress was making Katsuki feel more like himself.

Katsuki tried to focus, he tried to figure out *his* emotions. Maybe they could sort out what he was feeling and what Deku was feeling.

He was nervous. That was the major emotion in his heart at that moment. Nervous, and afraid. But there was also hope, hidden in there somewhere. A tiny little sparkle of it. Resentment, too, and that was probably coming from Katsuki.

But apart from the fear, the most alarming sensation, the strongest of them, was a sense of longing. Desire. *Need.* Katsuki found himself in need of Deku, and if they were truly back to sharing their feelings, whether it was because of the Soulmonger's quirk or because of the One For All transfer, that meant Deku was in need of Katsuki too.

Hope increased. But so did nervousness. Katsuki gave up on telling who was feeling what; the sentiments were becoming mixed and amalgamated and indistinguishable from each other.

"Yeah", Katsuki responded, suddenly sure that what Deku was saying was the truth.

Deku finally brought himself to look at Katsuki. There was a question written in his features.

"For how long?", Deku asked, seeming curious. Katsuki shrugged.

"I don't know", he admitted. "I just realized it now".

Deku stared at him for a moment before nodding in comprehension.

“I realized it two nights ago”, Deku admitted. “I woke up feeling so much *fear*”.

Katsuki felt heat rising to his cheeks and tried his best to suppress it, lest Deku see him blush.

“Don’t know what you’re talking about”, he said dismissively, not really willing to discuss that either. There was only *one* thing he wanted to discuss; why couldn’t they just get to it already and be done with it?!

“Do you want to tell me what happened?”, Deku insisted; of course he did.

Katsuki sighed, getting a little irritated. Still, he controlled himself as to avoid lashing out – the last thing he needed was for Deku to storm out and waste another day they could use to talk things out. Or maybe it wasn’t *him* who was irritated, but rather Deku, who had a weird look on his face as he waited for Katsuki’s response. Maybe his insisting on the kiss subject was finally getting on his nerves.

“Will you stay upset if I don’t?”, Katsuki raised an eyebrow.

Deku frowned.

“I’m not upset”, he claimed, which made Katsuki roll his eyes.

“No use lying to someone who can literally feel your emotions, dipshit”, he pointed out.

Deku lowered his head, embarrassed. It took him a few moments to reply.

“I’m not upset”, he admitted. “I just wish you were more honest with me”.

Katsuki stared at him. *He* was the one who needed to be more honest? When Deku kept dodging the kiss subject like his life depended on it?

“I know you’re afraid of looking weak or dependent or whatever”, Deku continued, “but you won’t. In my eyes, you will always be the very definition of victory, and nothing can ever change that”.

Katsuki stared at him, pensive. There it was again, *the definition of victory*. Was that all he was to Deku? A hero prototype? A hero *archetype?* He wanted to be more. He was dying to be more, even if he didn’t know what *more* meant. He wanted to be more to Deku than just his hero, just his friend, just his colleague, just his classmate, just his playmate. He wanted to be Deku’s everything, just as Deku had become his everything.

Time to be brave and face his worst enemy. The enemy that had made him turn away from Deku, the enemy that poisoned their relationship for so many years and made Katsuki make so many bad choices. The enemy who gnawed at his heart and whispered lies to his brain, the enemy that convinced him that Deku looked down on him, the enemy that told him lies about Deku and his altruistic behavior and his admiration for him.

His fear.

“I had a dream”, Katsuki said, tasting the words on his tongue, “and I didn’t know what it meant”.

Deku frowned at him, confused. He looked and sounded like he had expected a more complex excuse.

“Was that what scared you?”, he asked.

Katsuki looked like he would rather swallow lava than to reply to that question, but he nodded.

“I wouldn’t say *scare* is the right word”, he pointed out, a bit too defensively. “It just… shocked me”.

Deku stared at him in silence, worrying at his lower lip. Eventually, he nodded.

“It must have been a pretty strong shock, then, because I could feel it all the way back at the dorm”, he said tentatively, as if he didn’t fully believe in Katsuki.

Katsuki snorted, but remained silent. He didn’t want to tell Deku what had shocked him in the dream. He didn’t want to admit to his own weakness – telling Doctor Matsuo had been enough of an experience.

“I think we can only feel each other’s feelings when the emotion is very strong”, Deku added awkwardly, letting go of the hem of his shirt in order to rub the back of his neck. “Maybe it has to do with One For All, but it could be an after effect from the villain’s quirk”, he theorized. “We never really understood why my soul ended up with you and not with him, so maybe… Maybe it’s related”.

Katsuki nodded, silent. That would explain why Katsuki still felt shitty when Deku wasn’t there – whatever half-assed emotion Deku felt while he wasn’t there, stressing out because Katsuki was in a hospital, hadn’t been strong enough for Katsuki to feel it. Katsuki, in return, had spent most of his time sedated and sleeping, which meant he didn’t have much opportunity to share his emotions with Deku either. They only felt strongly when they were there with the other.

Deku was right – they didn’t know why the villain’s quirk had glued Deku’s soul to his. But it had happened. And it had led to everything they had lived throughout the past months, up to the kiss. Katsuki was desperate to know what Deku had thought of it, but the boy still seemed reluctant to talk. He didn’t know what else he could to show Deku how desperate he was for answers, even though he feared the answers he might get at the same time.

“Do you want to tell me what the dream was about?”, Deku asked, looking like it was taking all of his courage to do so. And if he was so reluctant – so uncomfortable – talking about this, should Katsuki really force him into it? Should he really risk this already strained friendship they had struggled so hard to build over this?

He was trying too hard to be the hero Deku saw him as and face his fear in the face, like Doctor Matsuo had suggested. But it was so *hard.* So fucking hard. He would rather face the

entirety of the League of Villains on his own, while injured, because that shit would be easier than talking about his feelings.

“No”, he admitted in a surge of cowardice.

Deku blinked at him. He seemed a little hurt.

“Why not?”, he inquired, as if he had any right to.

Katsuki felt petty. If Deku wasn’t talking about the kiss, then he wasn’t talking about the dream. There. How did Deku like their little secrets now? Katsuki turned his face away from him in anger and resentment, glaring at the wall parallel to his bed.

Deku must have sensed his anger because of their bond, or maybe he felt a glimpse of it. Confused, he took a step forward.

“Kacchan?”

Katsuki closed his eyes. Part of him wanted to rebel and tell Deku to fuck off, the other part wanted to do anything and everything to keep him close. He felt so confused and so *tired*. Tired of arguing, trying of dancing around each other like two wolves fighting for food. He just wanted things to be ok. He just wanted… He wanted…

More.

There was no escaping and he knew it. He would have to keep reminding himself of what he wanted, and of how he could get it. There was a chance Deku would reject him and Katsuki would lose him forever, but there was also a chance Deku would return his feelings and accept to give him his heart, just like Katsuki had given him his – even if the nerd didn’t know it. In the end, it was a 50/50 probability. He just needed to gather the strength and the courage he required to be true and honest in a way he had never allowed himself to be before.

He took a deep breath.

He was Bakugou fucking Katsuki. He could do this. *I can do this.*

“Because I’m afraid to ruin things”, he admitted, eyes fixed on the wall. He turned his head to look Deku in the eye, allowing the honesty he was feeling to pour out of his eyes.

Deku seemed surprised by that statement, but then something else glimmered in those expressive eyes of his. Katsuki couldn’t quite put a name to the feeling, but it was warm and welcoming.

“It’s ok to be afraid”, Deku told him gently.

Katsuki couldn’t help but to scoff and roll his eyes at this. It was such a Deku thing to say.

“Don’t patronize me”, he protested, but Deku was quick to answer.

“I’m not”, he said, biting at his lower lip for a moment before taking a seat at the edge of Kacchan’s bed. They were a lot closer to each other, now – closer than they had been in all of Deku’s other visits. Katsuki tried not to think too much about it. “I swear I’m not. I’m just trying to let you know that – whatever it is, it’s ok. You’re not going to ruin anything”, he reassured.

Katsuki huffed a laugh through his nose. Deku was acting so Deku-like that it was driving him insane. Katsuki didn’t know what he had expected, but a promise of complete acceptance should have been on the list. This was Deku, after all.

Still, he said:

“You can’t know that”.

Because Deku couldn’t. If he had hated the kiss, if he didn’t want to talk about it or even acknowledge it, how Katsuki go back to talking to him normally? Acting like they were friends when he wanted to be more? He couldn’t.

Now that he knew that he loved Deku, there was no going back anymore. He couldn’t simply go back to being just friends with him, not when he felt like this. And if Deku didn’t want him back – Katsuki couldn’t just accept that easily and keep talking to him as if nothing had happened. The solution would have to be pushing Deku away again, like he had done all those years, because he wouldn’t bear to be close to him without being able to be with him. Deku would probably find someone else, someone he really loved, and Katsuki wouldn’t be able to just stand there and watch someone he loved be with someone else.

He would have to push Deku away in order not to feel hurt. And it would ache. But it would be better to live with a dull pain than live with a constant, burning heartache. After all, that was one of the reasons why Katsuki had pushed Deku away in the first place, right? He had been afraid of him, yes, but he had also been afraid of the pain he would feel when Deku eventually got himself killed. Because he was a quirkless idiot who nevertheless acted like a hero, even when he couldn’t do shit to defend himself. And that was bound to send him to an early grave.

Katsuki himself had almost sent him to an early grave.

Deku gave him a reassuring look, a decisive look. He looked sure of himself, but still, Katsuki couldn’t help but to feel *fear*. It was raw, eating his insides, freezing the blood in his veins. And he felt stupid, but he couldn’t stop himself from feeling it. This was it. The decisive talk was coming.

“I can, because I won’t let it ruin anything”, Deku ensured.

Katsuki scoffed. Deku didn’t know what he was talking about.

“You wanted me to be more honest, right?”, he said, trying do diverge the attention. He wanted to talk about the kiss, but he was terrified to do so. He was trying to buy himself time, more time with Deku, more time before things changed for good.

“Yes”, Deku nodded without missing a beat.

Katsuki nodded back at him.

“Then here it goes”, he said. “I don’t know how to deal with you”.

Deku just blinked at him with the hint of a frown between his eyebrows.

“You make me feel things I don’t know how to feel”, Katsuki continued, feeling raw and honest. “Empathic bond or not. And you say stuff, and you act a certain way – that used to infuriate me, but now it doesn’t. I don’t know what to expect. I don’t know how to feel. And you keep acting as if I’m supposed to react in a certain way, but I don’t know what that is and I don’t know how to live up to your expectations. Which is ridiculous, considering you’re you and I’m me. I wasn’t supposed to want to live up to anyone else’s expectations, yet here I am”.

Deku nodded, signaling for him to go on.

“I don’t know what you want from me, Deku”, he admitted, shrugging. *I don’t know what I want from you, either.*

A pause.

“What do *you* want from me?”, Deku asked.

Fucking great.

“What?”, Katsuki narrowed his eyes and shook his head, sighing and pointing Deku with an impatient look.

“What do you want from me?”, Deku repeated, as if the question was simple. “Maybe if you figure that out, it will help you understand what I want from you”.

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“You’re not making any sense”, he said, heart beating faster. This was it. This was happening.

“Try it”, Deku encouraged him. “Maybe it will help”.

Katsuki’s mouth felt dry; there was a knot in his throat. He was running out of time. Things were about to change. Things would change for good, and forever, and he didn’t know how to deal with it. He tried to search his mind for every possible advice Doctor Matsuo had ever given him.

Good thoughts, good words, good deeds. If you keep pushing him away, you’ll both just freeze in winter weather. Chin up. Face your problems head on, lest they swallow you whole.

“If you can’t tell me how you got your quirk back”, Katsuki said tentatively, heart beating so fast inside his chest it felt like it felt like it was about to give out. “Why don’t you show me?”

Deku's face became red.

He was staring deep into Katsuki's eyes. Katsuki searched the green irises for a reaction, a response, but he couldn't interpret the look that Deku was giving him. He couldn't comprehend if he was down for it or if he was repulsed by the idea. But what was done, was done. Katsuki had already laid the suggestion; there was no backing out from it now. There was no backing down.

"Are you sure you want me to show you?", Deku asked. His face was blank, and Katsuki didn't know what he was feeling.

Wait. Their emotions were still connected. His fear was probably pouring over Deku. Or maybe the fear he was feeling was just a projection of Deku's. But what reason did Deku have to feel so afraid?

I still love you, Kacchan. I always have.

Katsuki swallowed past the knot in his throat.

"Yes", Katsuki replied simply. He was sure. He was so sure.

Deku hesitated.

"Does this… have to do with the dream?", he asked, voice barely above a whisper. He sounded like he was trying to prove a point to himself.

Katsuki stayed silent. He didn't really want to confirm or deny anything. He remembered the way he had felt when he first remembered about the dream – his emotions had been so intense that they were projected all the way back to Deku. There was a chance they were exchanging emotions in that very moment. If that was the case, then there was no point denying anything anymore. He needed to be brave and own up his emotions, his desires, his expectations.

He nodded.

Deku blushed.

He leaned forwards a bit in a way that didn't seem planned, but that Katsuki noticed with acute perception. He was trying to calculate how many centimeters were separating their mouths in his head. Deku's pink, moist lips were parted in way that made Katsuki lick his own lips, and he seemed nervous, but not… Repelled? That filled Katsuki with confidence, because he saw a spark of hope. He could feel his emotions irradiating towards Deku, flooding him, running through him.

They were face to face now, but Deku's eyes were glued to Katsuki's lips. They were so close to each other Katsuki could feel the gentle tickling sensation that accompanied Deku's breaths.

This was it. *Chin up. Be brave.*

They were closer than any friend should be. They had already crossed the event horizon – there was no going back from this now.

“Is this ok?”, Deku asked, voice low. Katsuki would have missed the words if it hadn’t been for Hatsume’s improved hearing aid.

He nodded softly, causing his nose to brush against Deku’s.

Deku’s eyes fluttered shut and he brushed his nose against Katsuki’s again, looking like he was enjoying the moment. For a moment, the whole world was resumed to them – noses brushing gently against each other, breaths coming out shallowly and heavily. There was innocence in that gesture. And yes, they had hugged, and shared a bed, and even cuddled before, but this – this felt like the apex of intimacy. This felt more electric than any of their shared touches from before.

Deku didn’t move. He had already gone through the job of closing most of the distance between them. They were millimeters apart.

Deku wouldn’t have gotten so close unless he wanted this, right?

Katsuki closed his eyes too, softly. For a moment, he just relished on the feeling of Deku’s nose brushing against his. He took in the scent of him, and the warmth irradiating from his freckled skin. It felt good. Katsuki liked it. Katsuki yearned for it.

He yearned for more.

Katsuki closed the distance between their lips, and they were finally kissing.

He was hesitant at first, but once he started, he couldn’t hold himself back. He pressed harder against Deku, feeling his warmth seep into his own skin, feeling his erratic pulse against him. It matched Katsuki’s own frantic heart.

This wasn’t enough. He wanted more. *More, Deku, please* –

He explored Deku’s lips with the tip of his tongue, licking at the lower lip as if requesting to enter his mouth. His lips were as soft as they had been in Katsuki’s dream, very different from that chapped, dry version that Katsuki had met in the wreckage. He tasted sweet, like chocolate, and Katsuki decided that there was no taste he liked better than Deku’s lips.

Deku opened his mouth and allowed Katsuki in, welcoming him with his own tongue. The kiss was messy, and warm, and wet – everything to be expected from two amateurs such as they were – but it was everything Katsuki could have wished for and more. He couldn’t help himself as his good hand moved out of its own volition and grabbed Deku, pulling him closer to himself.

Eventually, they broke away, both blushing and breathing heavily. Deku’s pupils were blown wide open, his face flushed a deep red and his lips moist and pink. Katsuki was pretty sure he was offering a similar look. Deku seemed to be at a loss for words, and so was Katsuki. He

simply sat there, his good hand still clinging to the front of Izuku's shirt. Realizing what he was doing, he let go, hand falling next to Deku's.

Deku hesitated, and then he gently placed his own hand atop Katsuki's. Katsuki stared at their own conjoined hands, before lifting his eyes to meet Deku's.

The nerd looked happy. He didn't look repulsed, or disgusted, or in any way repelled by what they had done. He looked *happy*. And Katsuki was relieved to say – he shared that happiness. Not just because of their empathic bond.

"Now what?", he asked. Because really, he had no idea where to go from there. Were they dating now? Were they boyfriends? Did Katsuki have to ask him officially or were they cool with this unspoken thing?

Deku averted his eyes, seeming embarrassed.

"I just want you to be happy, Kacchan", he said, hesitant. "However that might be".

Katsuki frowned. Why wasn't Deku looking him in the eye? He squeezed Deku's hand, trying to call his attention.

"Oi, nerd. Look at me".

Deku raised his eyes. Katsuki was still trying to kickstart his brain into working again, because the kiss he had just shared with Deku had short-circuited his neurons. But even in that dumbfounded state, he could see there was something weird about the way Deku was staring at him.

All right, then. Time for some more honesty. Even better – time for making Deku taste his own medicine, *during* honesty time.

"I'm gonna to say some stuff", Katsuki told him, still holding his hand, "And you're gonna reply with true or false. Deal?"

Deku chuckled, still a bit nervous. The image was a sight for Katsuki's sore eyes.

"You're copying me", he accused.

Katsuki huffed.

"Shut it. I care about you".

Deku blushed, looking away.

"True".

Katsuki nodded, swallowing dry.

"I want to make you happy, too. It's only right, after everything I put you through".

Deku stared at him, lost, as if he didn't know what to answer. Katsuki raised his eyebrows encouragingly.

"T-True…?", Deku tried hesitantly.

Ok, not very confident of him. Katsuki made a mental note to work harder on that subject as soon as possible.

"You're important to me", Katsuki said.

"T-True".

"And I don't know what love is".

Deku frowned. He didn't know about the talk about the seven loves Katsuki had discussed with Doctor Matsuo, so it was natural for him to be confused. Katsuki added:

"But you taught me that".

And it was true. Because the love he felt for Deku had been in his chest before he had learned how to name it. Doctor Matsuo had only helped him realize something that had been buried within him for a long, long time now. He couldn't pinpoint exactly when the feeling had started, but he could tell it had been in him for a while. Because he hadn't fallen for Deku – he had walked into love, with his eyes wide open, choosing to take every step along the way.

Tears pooled in Deku's eyes. Katsuki didn't find that too alarming, since the nerd was always crying, but he still hated the look of it. So he decided to continue.

"So even if I'm 'emotionally constipated', I know this: we have a long way ahead of us, we still have a lot of shit to figure out, but I want to try it out. I want to listen to Doctor Matsuo and try my best to live a happy life. Whether that's a life with meds or with you, I don't care".

Deku sniffed and Katsuki raised a hand to his face, cupping it gently in his palm. He wiped Deku's tears away with his thumb.

"Oi, Deku, stop crying", he said, half-authoritative, half-gentle. "You know I hate it when you cry".

Deku offered him a wet chuckle at this, lowering his eyes and smiling against Katsuki's hand.

"S-Sorry".

Katsuki huffed.

"Don't apologize".

Deku's smile withered a bit on his lips until just a shadow of it remained. He raised his big expressive eyes to look at Katsuki, hesitation evident in the way he looked at him.

“You really want this? You really want… *me*?”, he asked, nervous.

And fuck, what could Katsuki say to that? Did he *want* Deku? He had thought Deku didn’t want him! Yes, a thousand times, yes, he had literally dreamed about this, he had longed for this, he had been so afraid with no reason, because Deku wanted him back! There was nothing in the world Katsuki wanted more than to prove that to him, show that to him, how many times it was necessary.

“You’re my constant”, he said seriously, squeezing Deku’s hand again. “You’ve always been there, and I want to keep it that way. So what have you got to say?”

“True”, Deku sniffed, smiling wide. “It’s all true”.

Katsuki enveloped him in another kiss, and he had never been happier.

From: Best Friend

So, I finally figured out about the F-word

From: Shitty Hair

WHAT??????????????????????????

From: Shitty Hair

BAKUGOU YOU’RE SUPPOSED TO BE RESTING

From: Shitty Hair

YOU’RE IN THE HOSPITAL WHAT THE HELL

From: Shitty Hair

HOW DID YOU EVEN MANAGE TO DO IT

From: Shitty Hair

WHO DID YOU EVEN DO IT WITH

From: Shitty Hair

WAS IT MIDORIYA????????

From: Best Friend

OF COURSE IT WAS WHO ELSE WOULD I DO IT WITH

From: Best Friend

KIRISHIMA WHAT THE FUCK DO YOU THINK THE F-WORD IS

From: Shitty Hair

YOUR FAVORITE WORD

From: Shitty Hair

F***

From: Best Friend

WHAT THE HELL

From: Best Friend

NO

From: Best Friend

I'VE ALREADY TOLD YOU BEFORE THAT THE F-WORD IS FONDNESS DUMBASS

From: Shitty Hair

Oh

From: Shitty Hair

Ooooooooh

From: Shitty Hair

Now so many things make sense and I am SO RELIEVED YOU DIDN'T FUCK ANYONE WHILE RECOVERING FROM SURGERY

From: Shitty Hair

But you're the only one to blame here

From: Shitty Hair

Who the heck abbreviates fondness for the f-word????

From: Shitty Hair

How was I supposed to KNOW

From: Shitty Hair

And what do you mean you figured it out? What did you DO

From: Best Friend

I'm going to sleep now

From: Best Friend

Bye

From: Shitty Hair

NO BAKUGOU WAIT

From: Shitty Hair

YOU DIDN'T REPLY TO ANY OF MY MESSAGES SO FAR AND NOW YOU'RE JUST GOING TO DROP THIS BOMB ON ME AND SKEDADDLE LIKE IT'S NOTHING?????

From: Best Friend

Ok. We talked about our feelings and kissed. Everything's cool now. Good night

From: Shitty Hair

WHAT????????

Katsuki turned his phone off and went to sleep.

Chapter End Notes

Man, it feels so GOOD to come back to this story.
Let me start by saying that 2020 sucked ass. I was in a really bad mental state. I was paranoid (and I'm not just throwing this word around, I'm actually taking antipsychotics because of paranoia), I was anxious, I lost 6 kg because of pure stress. I thought people were out to get me, I kept thinking I would get doxxed or hacked or that someone would tell my parents about my sexual orientation. Long story short: I was doing poorly, and

internet just made everything worse.
So I started to isolate. I soft-blocked people on twitter, but then just looking at my tl became a massive toll. I was so stressed out I reached a point I couldn't even look at my phone out of fear that I would receive catastrophic news at any given moment. I stopped using twitter altogether for a few months - the same goes for tumblr and other social media. I stopped talking to close friends, I stopped answering messages, I stopped connecting with the world. I'd start crying for no reason when I woke up in the morning, I almost lost my job because I was performing so poorly.
But I got help. I came out to my mom, who supported me, and she helped me seek professional help (which I should have done years ago, but didn't, because I was afraid the meds were going to fuck me up. Does that ring any bells?). I already had a diagnosis of clinical anxiety, but my psychiatrist diagnosed me with depression and paranoia as well. I started taking meds. I gained 15 kg in six months because of them. I had a HORRIBLE adaptation phase while my medication was being adjusted. I went through half of the crazy-ass side effects people usually have when they start antidepressants and antipsychotics. But now, eight months later, I'm feeling so much better than before. I went back to twitter, I made new friends, I kept in touch with my old irls, I felt more creative, more motivated, more inspired. There are still days when I feel down, but they're becoming rarer and rarer. And this is why I decided to add two more chapters to this story. The 10K kudos thing was a nice opportunity to do so, but I actually wanted to write more of TWYUTD for a pretty personal reason.
I hope you can understand and forgive me for continuing this story after months of finishing it. When I published the final chapter and the epilogue, I was in the terrible mental state I just described. And I wasn't happy or satisfied with the ending. To me, it felt rushed, too simplistic, and too sudden. I hated it with all my heart, because I felt like my public deserved better. You guys kept up with this story for so long, and you've supported me so well, so I wanted to repay you accordingly. And now, here I am. Offering more. I hope you guys like it.
A lot of people told me they wanted to see Bakugou's POV from chapter 27, so here it is. Some people also told me they wanted more fluffy scenes + their friends' reactions to them dating + their parents' reactions + R-rated times. These are all coming up in the second part of the celebratory chapters.
I hope this managed to quench your thirst for bakudeku. As always, thanks for reading and supporting me, and kudos + comments are always very appreciated!

Extra kudos for those of you who get the TSoA reference.

P.S.: A lot of you asked in the comments what the "f-word" was. All this time, Kirishima has been thinking Katsuki wanted to f*** Deku. Who's to blame him? Katsuki will say f*** every other phrase, but when it comes to saying "fondness" his brain just freezes. Anyway.

Chapter 29: An Ending

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Katsuki was happy.

Well, that was something hard to say when he was literally stuck to a hospital bed like an invalid, but the truth? The truth was he was happy.

First? Things were solved between himself and Deku.

He knew their arguments weren't over. He knew they would still fight every now and then. But their endless cycle of fighting over the same things, their endless and pointless discussions over the same issues, *that* was finally over. And he was glad – he really was, because things were good between them for once and it was so satisfying not to be defensive all the time.

Second? Things were *good* between them. For what was probably the first time ever.

Before, even when they were kids, Katsuki had always looked down on Deku. Now, they were standing on the same level. They were finally equals – from Deku's point of view and from Katsuki's as well. And as much as they were still rivals, they were better at being so – the competition was finally fair.

Third? Katsuki had found a side of himself he never knew he had.

Let's be honest. Katsuki wasn't a romantic. He had never even considered romance, or love, or something as silly as infatuations, until Deku came along with that stupid dimpled smile of his. And now that they had kissed – properly, this time –, Katsuki was certain of one thing: if he was going to waste his time on this lovey-dovey type of thing, then Deku was the only person he wanted to waste his time on.

They had gone through too much, overcome too much, for him to keep pretending they weren't deeply involved with each other. Not only because of the feelings they were still sharing and the bond they still had, but because of everything else. The way Deku's praise made Katsuki's heart race, the way his simple presence was enough to make Katsuki feel more like himself while he was in the medbay. The way Deku's smile made his chest feel warm, the way his absence made him feel so much longing for him.

Katsuki wasn't a romantic, but Deku certainly made him feel like one. And it felt stupid – it really did – but he didn't mind. For once, he really didn't mind what other people would think – all that mattered was what Deku thought, and what Deku had to say about it.

Katsuki had watched the boy die twice. He had lost him more times than that. They had fought, and argued, and stopped talking to each other several times over and over. He didn't

bother hiding it anymore – he cared what Deku thought. And to hell with anyone who dared to mock him about that.

Learning he was taking anxiety meds had been hard, but Doctor Matsuo reassured him that this wouldn't be forever. They would have to change his medication because of the nasty side effects it had on him – all the dizziness and low blood pressure –, but they would thread carefully until he was comfortable and well adjusted. And Katsuki hated the idea of relying on medication to stay true to himself, because of something as unexpected to him as anxiety, but he knew, deep down, that taking a couple pills every day was better than having those bad freak-out sessions (which Aizawa sensei referred to as *panic attacks*) that made him feel so overwhelmed and tired and scared.

Katsuki didn't scare easily. He wanted to keep things that way, even if that meant taking meds.

It wasn't forever. It was just a temporary solution; one he was willing to take for the sake of his own health. It seemed that being stressed all the time wasn't good for your heart, and he needed to be on his best shape in order to be the best hero.

"Happy, Kacchan?"

"You can't even imagine".

"Everyone is so glad you'll be returning today! I think the guys are throwing a party".

"Good luck for them. I'm going straight to my bedroom".

"*Kacchan*".

"What? You know I hate parties".

A pause.

"Well, you *should* rest… But maybe stick around for a few minutes? Just so they can talk to you and see you're fine?"

“They’ll see I’m fine when I climb my way past them and up the stairs without help”.

“Just because your arms are better –“

“We’re not arguing over this, Deku. Once I’m out of here, I’m headed straight to my bed”.

“But –“

“And you’re coming with me”.

Blushing silence.

“Nothing to say for yourself, nerd?”, a smirk.

“*Kacchan*…”

“What?”

“Won’t they… You know”.

“I don’t”.

“… Talk?”

A pensive pause.

“Definitely”.

“And you don’t mind?”

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“I’m the best of the best. They’ll always talk about me, no matter what. I might as well ignore their little extra chatter”.

Izuku scoffed.

“Back to pretending you don’t care about their opinion of you?”

“I don’t, actually”, he admitted. “Not about this, anyway”.

Izuku blushed.

“Are you serious?”

“Dead serious”.

“Don’t joke about death”.

“I wasn’t”.

“Oh”.

“Yeah”.

Silence.

“Yeah, ok”.

“Ok?”

“I’ll go to your room with you”, Izuku clarified. “If you want me to”.

“I wouldn’t have invited you if I didn’t want you to, dipshit”.

“Rude”.

“Yeah, and you like it”.

“Shut up”, a chuckle.

A pause.

“I still think we should stop by for just a little bit –“

“*Deku*”.

“They’re waiting for you, Kacchan! Everyone has been so worried –“

“I’m going to smother you with my pillow, nerd”.

“ – and they deserve the chance to talk to you! Not everyone has been able to visit, you know”.

“Yeah, I noticed that”.

“Hatsume-san has been working herself crazy trying to build you a new hearing aid”.

“What for?”

“To thank you, I guess. For saving her life”.

“And breaking her arm”.

“You didn’t break her arm; you dislodged her shoulder”.

“Same difference when it comes to her line of job”, Katsuki scoffed. “She needs her arms to be functional in order to work”.

“She recovered fast”, Izuku pointed out. “Also, I’m pretty sure she’d rather have one less functional arm than to die in an explosion, so she’s pretty grateful you did what you did”.

“Yeah, whatever”.

A pause.

“You’re being uncharacteristically unwilling to take praise over this”.

“I don’t want praise. Not for what I did”.

“Why not? That was the most heroic –“

“No”.

“W-What?”

“I didn’t do what I did because I was trying to be heroic”.

A pause.

“My legs moved before I could really think about it”.

Silence.

“You know… All Might once told me that’s the essence of being a hero”.

Katsuki stared at him.

“It happened to me too”, Izuku continued. “Back with the sludge villain. And back at the debris as well. I wasn’t trying to be heroic. I just saw you were in danger, and I had to move”.

Katsuki’s chest boiled with warmness and rage.

“And do you want praise?”

“For what?”

“For what you did”.

“Of course not”.

“There. I don’t want it either. I was just trying to save my friends”.

Another pause.

“I… I understand”.

“Good”.

“But still, I want you to know that I think you were very heroic”.

“I ain’t gonna tell you the same. I’m still pissed about it”.

“You’re pissed?!”

“Trashmouth”.

“What did I do?!”

“You broke a police barricade and ran into a fallen building! *And* you had a concussion, don’t think I forgot about that”.

“Kacchan. You can’t be serious”.

“I’m dead serious”.

“*Stop* using that expression. And you can’t be serious because we’ve talked about it!”

“Yeah”.

“And you were fine with it!”

“It was the damn meds, Deku. I’m pissed, I’m just not stressed over it”.

“That doesn’t make any sense”.

“Yeah, it does”.

“No it doesn’t!”

“Yeah, it does! I’m pissed at you”.

“Kacchaaaan”.

“What?”

“I don’t want you to be mad at me!”

“You shouldn’t have risked your life, then!”

“I had to save you!”

“I don’t need –“

“Don’t say you don’t need saving”.

“I was about to”.

“I know”.

“And I don’t need saving”.

“Kacchan. Come on”.

“I mean it”.

“I know you’re proud –“

“It’s not about pride –“

“ – But if I hadn’t gotten to you, who knows what would have happened?”

Katsuki felt nauseous.

“Let’s not talk about it”.

“I think we need to talk about it”.

“Just because I’m pissed?”

“Exactly because of that!”

“Just let it go, Deku. I only got pissed because I worry about you”.

“I worry about you too”.

“I know”.

“I know you know. And I know you worry about me, too”.

“Tch. We sound like two old guys having an argument”.

“We’re about to look old, too”.

“Watcha mean?”

“I’m about to wheelchair you out of this room”.

A scoff.

“As if I’m getting outta here on a wheelchair”.

“You are”.

“No, I ain’t”.

“You are –“

“I’m walking out of here, Deku”.

“Come on, Kacchan”.

“Don’t argue with me over this. I’m walking and that’s final”.

“Kacchaaaan”.

“Be my cane, nerd”.

Katsuki was happy.

As he lied in bed with Deku in his arms – after stopping by at the welcome party and talking to his over-excited friends, of course –, there was nowhere else in the world he’d rather be. There was no pillow fort between them anymore, and there didn’t have to be.

He still had a long path ahead of him. Recovering properly – becoming the number one hero – neither of those were easy tasks.

But the things he loved the most in the world always had to be complicated – take Deku, for instance. Becoming number one was just another thing he had to overcome with time, until he became great at it. He would have to struggle a little, he would have to work his way around his difficulties, but at the end of the day, his effort would be rewarded.

Katsuki never liked to have things easy, after all.

Chapter End Notes

It's hard to say goodbye to this story, so I wrote a small piece that's supposed to serve as closure.

Thanks for all the comments and encouragement from the final chapter! This really is the last one, I promise (but there WILL be a sequel).

Chapter 30: The End of the Beginning

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

From: Shitty Hair

Ok, so

From: Shitty Hair

I wanted to ask you a question

From: Shitty Hair

I don't really know if the answer you'll give me will actually answer it

From: Shitty Hair

So please try your best because I've been dying to know the answer and I am literally receiving death threats from our friends over this

From: Shitty Hair

Can I go ahead?

From: Best Friend

Just spit it

From: Shitty Hair

All right

From: Shitty Hair

Here I go

From: Shitty Hair

Are you and Midoriya

From: Shitty Hair

Um

From: Shitty Hair

Dating?

From: Best Friend

My answer to you is:

From: Best Friend

None of your business

From: Shitty Hair

Bakugou COME ON

From: Shitty Hair

Did you not read the part where I say I'm receiving DEATH THREATS

From: Shitty Hair

All our friends can sense I know something about this

From: Shitty Hair

Because you told me about the f-word and you told me you guys kissed???

From: Shitty Hair

And then you arrived at the welcome party together but everyone knew that you guys had made up during your time at the hospital, since Midoriya was the only one who could visit you and all that

From: Shitty Hair

So no one thought too much about you two arriving and leaving together

From: Shitty Hair

But I have no idea if you're ok with me sharing what you told me with them, so I didn't tell them anything

From: Shitty Hair

And I'm not even sure if there's SOMETHING to tell, because you won't speak to me about what happened

From: Shitty Hair

Do you not want to do this over text? Is that the reason? Because I can totally stop by at any given time and we can have this talk in person

From: Shitty Hair

Is that ok?

From: Best Friend

You can't come over

From: Shitty Hair

Why not?

From: Best Friend

Deku's fast asleep in my arms and I don't want you to wake him up

From: Shitty Hair

Dude are you SHITTING ME

From: Shitty Hair

WE NEED TO TALK ABOUT THIS BAKUGOU I'M BEING SERIOUS

From: Shitty Hair

So you guys ARE dating?

From: Best Friend

What does it matter to you?

From: Shitty Hair

Well, what does it matter to YOU? Why do you keep acting so mysterious about it?

From: Best Friend

Look, Shitty Hair

From: Best Friend

This is all very new to me

From: Best Friend

We kissed and we're hanging out and we're sharing a bed and we talked about our feelings

From: Best Friend

But I don't know how to do this

From: Best Friend

I've never even thought about romance before

From: Best Friend

But what I do know is that kissing someone and telling them about your feelings isn't enough to claim you're dating them

From: Shitty Hair

What do you mean? Of course it's enough, people start dating with less than that!

From: Best Friend

No, it's not

From: Best Friend

Not to me

From: Best Friend

If I'm going to do this, then I'm going to be the best of the best. Deku will never want or need anyone else ever again, because I'll be the best boyfriend in this motherfucking world.

From: Best Friend

And for that, I need to do the proper ritual.

From: Best Friend

Making out in the middle of a wrecked building while one of us was dying doesn't exactly count as a first date

From: Best Friend

Neither does Frenching each other at Recovery Girl's medbay

From: Best Friend

So I'll start with that. As soon as I'm well enough

From: Best Friend

THEN, and only then, you'll be able to say we're dating

From: Best Friend

I don't give a shit what anyone will think about it, and I couldn't care less about what you'll tell them

From: Best Friend

But this is how this is gonna go.

From: Best Friend

Plus, I don't know if Deku wants everyone to know just yet. We haven't talked about it.

From: Shitty Hair

What do you

From: Shitty Hair

What do you mean you made out on the wreckage

From: Shitty Hair

YOU AND MIDORIYA MADE OUT WHILE YOU WERE DYING???????????

From: Best Friend

It totally slipped my mind you didn't know about this. But yeah

From: Best Friend

Ask Pikachu about it

From: Shitty Hair

KAMINARI KNOWS??????

From: Shitty Hair

YOU TOLD HIM BUT NOT ME?????

From: Best Friend

Deku told me he saw it

From: Best Friend

Not my fault

From: Best Friend

Bye

From: Shitty Hair

OH NO YOU DON'T

From: Shitty Hair

COME RIGHT BACK HERE MISTER

From: Shitty Hair

HOW COME KAMINARI KNEW AND I DIDN'T?

From: Shitty Hair

HOW COULD YOU DO THIS TO MEEEEE

From: Shitty Hair

I THOUGHT WE WERE BEST BROS

From: Best Friend

You sound gayer than I am

From: Shitty Hair

THIS IS SO UNFAIR

From: Best Friend

Are you gonna get touchy-feely about it?

From: Shitty Hair

You're damn right I will

From: Best Friend

How is it my fault he saw it and you didn't?!

From: Best Friend

He doesn't know we kissed after that. You do. So there you go, you're even now

From: Best Friend

When did this shit turn into a friendship match anyway

From: Shitty Hair

When you let him see it instead of me

From: Best Friend

I didn't LET him see shit, he saw it by accident

From: Best Friend

And if you're by any means implying that at some point I'll have to let you watch me and Deku French kiss each other I have terrible news for you

From: Shitty Hair

So Kaminari gets to see it but I don't?

From: Best Friend

STOP TALKING LIKE A PERVERT

From: Shitty Hair

STOP NOT TELLING ME ABOUT STUFF

From: Best Friend

Bye Kirishima

From: Shitty Hair

Bye Bakugou

From: Best Friend

Oh, so you're gonna act like this?

From: Shitty Hair

I just thought you trusted me better

From: Best Friend

Of course I trust you, dipshit

From: Best Friend

You're the only person I told about the f-word and about the kiss

From: Best Friend

You knew about the f-word before even Deku did, even though you're dumb and assumed I was talking about fucking

From: Best Friend

Kaminari happened to walk into us kissing. I told you about the kiss voluntarily

From: Best Friend

So stop throwing a tantrum and let me go take a nap

From: Shitty Hair

You can go take your nap, I'm not stopping you

From: Best Friend

You're mad at me, so no

Shitty Hair is typing…

Shitty Hair is typing…

From: Shitty Hair

… Since when do you care about that?

From: Best Friend

I've had two grave head injuries in a short time span and I literally almost died after a building fell on me

From: Best Friend

And yeah, maybe it's the after effect of the head injury talking, but I don't know what else I have to say to make you understand that you're important to me

From: Best Friend

I clearly suck at this type of thing, given the number of arguments I've had with Deku in the past because I cared too much and he mistook it for despise

From: Best Friend

And I'm not even counting the times he was the one who cared about me and I was the one who mistook it for despise

From: Best Friend

And I do think you're being a big baby over this

From: Best Friend

Let's be real, I told you way more than I would have done if this conversation had happened at any point of the past year

From: Best Friend

So just take what you can get and be done with it

From: Shitty Hair

Bakubro…

From: Shitty Hair

I'm crying manly tears right now

From: Shitty Hair

You've grown so much

From: Best Friend

You're ridiculous, Shitty Hair

From: Shitty Hair

I mean it

From: Shitty Hair

And I know exactly what I'm going to do

From: Shitty Hair

I'm going to give you a hand on the Midoriya thing

From: Best Friend

What thing?

From: Shitty Hair

The first date thing

From: Best Friend

And what sort of experience do you have in that field again?

From: Shitty Hair

None, which is why I'm calling in Mina, Kami and Sero to help

From: Best Friend

Oh, of course

From: Best Friend

Because they definitely know more than you do about this area

From: Shitty Hair

Stop being grumpy and listen to me

From: Shitty Hair

You and Midoriya are going to have the best first date of the history of first dates

From: Shitty Hair

That's a promise

From: Shitty Hair

So

From: Shitty Hair

Kami already knows, but is it ok if I tell the others?

From: Shitty Hair

They've been dying to know what's going on and the way you two behaved at the welcoming party just made everyone more curious

From: Shitty Hair

I won't say you two are dating, I'll just say you dig each other and you kissed

From: Shitty Hair

If that's ok with you, of course

From: Shitty Hair

But they kinda need to know if they're going to help with the first date

Katsuki lowered his phone and looked at Deku, who had his head resting against Katsuki's chest.

"Oi, Deku", Katsuki called softly. The sleeping boy stirred and nestled closer to Katsuki. "You awake?"

"Hmm", Deku hummed low, enveloping Katsuki's thin waist with his arm and holding him close.

"Shitty Hair wants to know if it's ok to tell people we kissed", Katsuki said in a low voice, not wanting to disturb him.

“We kissed”, he felt Deku smile against his chest, still half-asleep.

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“Yeah, we did. Do you want to keep it a secret or…?”

Deku frowned. He lifted his head to look at Katsuki, eyes half-lidded from sleepiness.

“Don’t our friends know we’re together?”, he questioned.

Katsuki shrugged.

“Well, we didn’t make anything official. The only ones who know we made out are Dunce Face and Shitty Hair”.

“Oh”, Izuku blinked. “Well, I don’t mind”.

“Are you sure?”, Katsuki raised an eyebrow.

Izuku smiled again, burying his face on Katsuki’s chest again and nestling closer to him.

“Of course I’m sure”, he mumbled, sleepy. “Kissing Kacchan is something to boast about, not to keep a secret”.

Katsuki rolled his eyes again, but there was an affectionate smile on his lips.

“Go back to sleep, nerd”.

“Hmm”.

From: Best Friend

Look, we don’t give a shit what you tell them

From: Best Friend

I just don’t want anyone harassing us or making a scene over this. Make sure everyone knows this

From: Best Friend

I’ll blow up anyone who makes me or Deku uncomfortable

From: Best Friend

And as for the first date, I don’t need nor want your help

From: Best Friend

I have to do this on my own

From: Shitty Hair

But Bakugou

From: Best Friend

It has to come from me

From: Best Friend

After everything that happened, it has to be me. Not someone else's stolen idea. Me. Alone.

From: Shitty Hair

But dude

From: Shitty Hair

We both know you'll probably come up with some shit that is NOT romantic

From: Shitty Hair

Like idk. A sparring session. Or watching a gore-y movie

From: Shitty Hair

Those are manly, but not first date material

From: Best Friend

Who says first dates can't be manly?

From: Shitty Hair

Bakugouuuuuu

From: Shitty Hair

I'm just trying to help

From: Best Friend

I know you are

From: Best Friend

Don't break a sweat over it.

From: Best Friend

I'll figure it out myself.

From: Shitty Hair

So what do I do?

From: Shitty Hair

I want to help

From: Shitty Hair

I really do, and this is not me wanting to be a part of your relationship, it's just

From: Shitty Hair

After everything that happened since that villain attacked you two

From: Shitty Hair

After everything you've faced, everything you've lost, everything you went through

From: Shitty Hair

I just want you to be happy, man

From: Shitty Hair

Midoriya too, of course

From: Shitty Hair

The two of you, together

From: Best Friend

I know you do

From: Best Friend

But this is something I have to do alone

From: Best Friend

Like you said, you're not a part of my relationship

From: Best Friend

But you're still my best friend

From: Best Friend

So just do whatever the fuck best friends do. Be supportive etc.

From: Shitty Hair

I'm gonna cry actual tears here buddy

From: Best Friend

Shut up

From: Best Friend

I'm actually gonna take a nap now, so bye

From: Shitty Hair

Ok

From: Shitty Hair

Sleep tight

From: Shitty Hair

And Bakugou?

From: Best Friend

What?

From: Shitty Hair

I'm really happy to see how much you've grown

Best Friend is typing…

Best Friend is typing…

Best Friend is typing…

From: Best Friend

Yeah. Me too.

Izuku woke up from a pleasant dream that slipped away from his memory as soon as he blinked his eyes open.

The first thing he saw was Kacchan sitting on his rolling chair by the study desk, facing his laptop. He was distracted – there was one hand supporting his head as he read the screen – and he didn't notice Izuku was awake, too focused on whatever he was doing on his computer. He was wearing his reading glasses, which sent butterflies to Izuku's stomach and a soft, fond smile to his lips. He just stared at the boy for a few moments, taking in the way he kept touching and squeezing his lower lip while he worked, probably not even realizing what he was doing.

"Can you pinpoint the moment you fell in love with me?", Izuku asked with a sleepy voice, still coming away from that pleasant haze of being unconscious, and Katsuki jolted on his seat, taken by surprise by his voice. He immediately slammed his laptop shut, as if he was seeing something prohibited, but Izuku didn't really pay it any attention. Instead, he focused on the pink tone Kacchan's cheeks were becoming, continuing to smile as the boy turned to him. He looked dazzling.

"I didn't know you were awake", Katsuki said with a defensive tone, taking his reading glasses off now that he no longer needed them and placing them on the desk.

Izuku shook his head.

"I just woke up", he said, and then he yawned. Now that Kacchan knew he was awake, he took the opportunity to stretch on the bed like a cat, groaning as he did so. He settled back down once he was done and sighed dreamily, lying on his stomach and hugging one pillow to his chest. "But tell me – can you?"

"Can I what?", Katsuki frowned, clearly not following.

"The moment you fell in love with me", Izuku clarified. "Can you pinpoint when it was?"

Katsuki blinked at him for a few moments. Sensing his confusion, Izuku continued.

"I can. I mean, I remember it clearly. It was back when I was still a ghost. You were helping me out with the notes from our class. Then you took your reading glasses and you put them on so you could read Kirishima-kun's notes better", he said. "That was the moment I realized I had it really bad for you".

Katsuki narrowed his eyes, squinting at Izuku with disbelief in his eyes.

"*Really?*", he asked with a scoff. "*That* was the moment?"

“Hey, don’t criticize it”, Izuku sat up on the bed, still hugging the pillow, and crossing his legs beneath himself. “It was a simple moment. Don’t people say there’s love in simplicity?”

“I’ve never heard that”, Katsuki pointed out. “Bet you’re just making that up”.

“Am not!”

“Are too”.

“Am *not*. And even if I was, I still like that moment. It wasn’t something big, with a playing orchestra and a cinematic reveal or anything. It was just – routine. Daily life”, he shrugged. “I mean, I knew I loved you before, but it wasn’t *love* love. It was just… love. And now it’s *looove*”.

Katsuki’s squint became even more intense. He looked like he’d just seen someone barfing.

“You’re not making any sense”, he accused.

Izuku sighed, shoulders sagging.

“It makes sense in my head”.

“I bet you say that a lot”.

“*Kacchan*”.

Katsuki huffed a small breath through his nose.

“I don’t think you’re going to like my answer”, he settled for saying.

“Why not?”, Izuku frowned, interested.

“It’s not cute and it’s definitely not romantic”, Katsuki pointed out. “It’ll probably disappoint you”.

Izuku giggled.

“As if you could *ever* disappoint me”.

Katsuki gave him a look. It was serious and full of meaning; the hint of phantom pain written in his eyes. Izuku let some of his humor slip away from his expression as he realized that Kacchan was taking this talk more seriously than he was.

“It’s not like I never disappointed you before”, Katsuki pointed out, grim.

Izuku’s smile faltered, but he didn’t look away. He reached out a hand to Katsuki and took it in his own, putting a special effort into clinging to his post-nap good humor.

“Look… We’ve talked about this”, he said, with a calm and encouraging tone. “It’s water under the bridge. After everything that happened…”, he shrugged, smiling again. “There’s no

point in either of us getting upset over stuff we can no longer change. We've both atoned, ok?"

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

"Yeah. We've both died, that's what we did".

Izuku sighed, pursing his lips together to form a thin line.

"*That*, too. But we're ok, now. And you can tell me, whatever it is", he squeezed Katsuki's hand encouragingly. "I promise I won't be let down. And it won't change the result, either. You'll still love me after you tell me, right?"

Katsuki sighed.

"Yeah".

"So, there", Izuku smiled softly. "That's the only thing that matters".

Katsuki rolled his eyes again. He took a deep breath, huffed the air out through his nose, and said:

"Fine. It was during a session with Doc Matsuo".

Izuku's eyebrows raised in surprise, but he didn't say anything. Neither did Katsuki.

Silence.

"So… Do you want to tell me more about it or…?"

Katsuki sighed, throwing his head back.

"She was probably in pain from watching my oblivious ass struggle with my obvious feelings. So she started telling me about shit from Ancient Greece and the seven types of loves. She kept rubbing that shit on my nose to see if I'd catch the hint, and then I did. I finally realized what my feelings were all about. And here we are", he shrugged.

Izuku could tell he was trying to put up a tough façade, but he now knew better enough to read the insecurity in Katsuki's eyes.

"That's lovely, Kacchan", he smiled widely, dimples appearing on his cheeks. "That's – That's really nice".

"Oh, fuck off with that", Katsuki removed his hand from Deku's grip, aggravated. "You know that's a shitty way to figure out your feelings. A therapist, spelling it out to you like you have a brain injury".

"No, it's not! And you *did* have a brain injury, in case that helps".

“I’m not saying *your way* was better”, Katsuki pointed out, defensive – too defensive. “I mean, really? Staring at my *face* did the trick for you? I knew I was amazing, but I didn’t think that just sitting here and existing would be enough for someone to fall in love”.

It was Izuku’s time to roll his eyes.

“You’re deflecting”, he accused.

Katsuki turned back to his studying desk.

“There’s nothing to deflect”, he said, not looking at Izuku. “I just told you how it went, and that was it”.

Izuku nodded slowly, his eyes never leaving Katsuki’s face.

“I liked it”, he admitted. “I don’t mind that you needed some help to figure it out, if that’s what’s bothering you”.

Katsuki eyed him from the corners of his eyes. He seemed hesitant.

“You really don’t?”, he raised an inquiring eyebrow.

Izuku shook his head, still smiling.

“Nope. Not one bit”.

Katsuki huffed. Then, he averted his eyes back to his closed laptop.

“Well, it’s almost dinner time”, Izuku commented, trying to diffuse the tension. He flopped back on the bed, lying on his back and staring at the ceiling. “What do you wanna eat?”

Katsuki shrugged.

“Whatever, I don’t really have a preference”, he said. “I need to take my meds in a bit and Recovery Girl said I shouldn’t take them on an empty stomach, so anything will do the trick”.

Izuku immediately sat back up at the mention of his medication, staring at Katsuki with something akin to alarm.

“Oh, let’s go eat, then”, he said promptly, as if Katsuki’s diet had suddenly become the number one priority in his life.

Katsuki rolled his eyes and stood up from his chair, walking towards Izuku and placing two hands on his shoulders. He slowly pushed the boy back until he was lying on the bed again, and then he climbed the mattress too, placing himself with one hand and one knee on either of Deku’s sides until he was on all fours above the boy.

Izuku studied his face with curious eyes, watching him and waiting for him to make a move. Katsuki, on the other hand, just stayed there for a while, looking deeply into Izuku’s green orbs and taking in the sight of him.

An eternity of silence passed. It wasn't awkward or pregnant for once, it was just silence. A moment of peace and quiet in their increasingly troublesome lives.

"I'm glad we figured our shit out", Katsuki finally said after a few moments.

Izuku smiled and nodded.

"I'm glad, too", he said. "Though I don't know if it's good for either of us to be so calm and… peaceful".

Katsuki snorted out a laugh.

"Because of the side effects of my quirk?", he raised an eyebrow.

Izuku nodded.

"I have it too, now. So who knows when I'll start sweating nitroglycerin and make myself pass out because of a lowered heart beat".

Katsuki made a face and removed himself from the top of Deku, sitting beside him instead. Since Deku was still lying down, he could only see the back of Katsuki's head in that position. And it seemed like that was just what Katsuki wanted – to turn his back on Izuku, so that he couldn't see his face. Izuku frowned and propped himself up with one elbow, blinking.

"Did… Did I say something wrong?"

Katsuki shrugged and shook his head.

"It's not a big deal".

Izuku worried at his lower lip, noticing the way Katsuki seemed to be avoiding his eyes.

"It is if you won't look at me".

Katsuki sighed and turned his head to stare at Izuku through the corners of his eyes. With a sigh and a pained groan – his injury was still healing, after all –, he lied down beside Deku on the bed. They were both lying side by side now, horizontal in relation to the vertical bed, which meant their knees bent over the edge of the mattress and their calves dangled off the edge too. They were lying on their backs, and they turned their heads to face each other directly in the eye.

"I've always seen my quirk as something unique", Katsuki admitted, tone soberer and quieter than usual. "I mean, it's the perfect mix of my parents' quirks. No one else in the world has anything like it".

Izuku rarely saw this side of Katsuki – the analytical, introspective side that contrasted so harshly against his booming voice and explosive personality. To him, it felt as if he was experiencing something exclusive – a side of Kacchan that had its defensive walls and its

tough façade lowered down just for him. It felt like he had finally earned Kacchan's trust, just as much as Kacchan had earned his.

Izuku nodded to indicate he could continue.

Katsuki turned his head so that he would be staring at the ceiling, breaking eye contact.

"But now… You have it too".

Izuku stared at him for a while before nodding.

"I see", he said. "I'm – I'm sorry".

Katsuki huffed out a breath, shaking his head.

"The hell are you even apologizing for?", he asked, staring straight ahead.

Izuku frowned in confusion, his mouth opening and closing a few times before he figured out what he wanted to say.

"I… I thought you were upset".

Katsuki clicked his tongue.

"Tch. I'm not mad at you, if that's what you're thinking", he clarified, which sent a wave of relief through Izuku. "I'm just… I don't know. I'm not really comfortable with the idea, but I'm not *angry* at you. I only took One For All to save your life, and I'd rather have you steal my quirk than to have you die on me", he said, sober. "But that doesn't mean it doesn't make me feel… weird. Like an itch I can't scratch".

Izuku turned to stare at the ceiling too, pensive. It took him a while to respond.

"I wouldn't say I stole your quirk", he said. "I just… have a backup copy of it. And I won't ever use it, if you don't want me to".

Katsuki was silent for a moment.

Then, he turned his head back towards Izuku, looking at him. Izuku did the same and they locked eyes. No one spoke for what felt like an eternity.

"It's ok if it's you", Katsuki said eventually.

Izuku smiled.

"We could make a deal", he proposed. "Since you said you won't ever use One For All, I can do the same and promise you I won't ever use your quirk. That's one less trouble for me, actually".

Katsuki frowned. Izuku shrugged playfully and continued:

“This way, I won’t have to constantly stress myself out to make up for the nitroglycerin poisoning”.

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“Yeah, leave the stress part for me”, he scoffed.

Izuku grabbed his hand, sobriety hitting him and making him sharply aware of his own existence.

“You won’t have to do this alone”, he promised.

Katsuki smirked teasingly.

“Knew I could count on you to stress me out”.

Izuku rolled his eyes.

“I’m not talking about that”.

“I know. Learn to take a joke”.

“*Kacchan*”.

Katsuki turned on the bed so that he was closer to Deku, passing one arm above the boy’s stomach and nestling his head on the crook of Deku’s neck. The proximity they had seemed to develop in such a little timespan was comfortable, and even if the old Katsuki wouldn’t have ever seen himself cuddling with Deku in his near future, he was also reminded of the dawn of their ghost times together, when hugging and cuddling didn’t seem all that alarming anymore.

Maybe it didn’t have to be. Maybe he could *indulge* in this. What did he have to lose?

He had already lost.

Once, in the alley.

Deku’s eyes were dead.

Twice, in the sewers.

“Y-You can feel it?”

“I can’t. Not anymore”.

Thrice, in the medbay.

“You’re saying he doesn’t remember his time as a shitty ghost?”

“What’s on your mind?”, Izuku asked gently, hugging Kacchan and holding him close to his chest with one hand.

Katsuki shrugged, grim. He did have a lot of time to think about everything that had happened, from day one, now that he was recovering from his injury. His proximity to near-death and Deku's similar experience were haunting and not particularly easy to digest, and he often found himself stuck in a blue mood when he thought about it. When he thought about what they had overcome, and how much things had changed between them. They were at a comfortable little spot now, but what about their future?

They both wanted to become pros. Getting injured and even losing their lives was nothing other than occupational hazard. And the main reason Katsuki pushed Deku away was because Deku was a dumb little hedgehog who kept toughing up his spines even though he started out with no quirk and no means to follow his dream. And yet, he still acted like he wasn't a hedgehog. He acted like he was a tiger. And that was bound to send him to an early grave.

In a subconscious level, Katsuki had always known he wouldn't be able to live through Izuku's death.

He knew so from his own past experience.

But they were together, now. And they were happy, cuddling, holding each other and being there for each other. But what would happen when the time came for them to fight evil again? When another villain arose? What would happen when Deku went on a mission Katsuki couldn't follow? What would happen when Deku, his Deku, his love, got injured?

Ok, enough of that far-future thinking. He didn't have to go that far. What would happen when *he* hurt Deku again? Because that was all he seemed to do, right? From day one. He had felt Deku's pain when they were tied together as a boy and a ghost, and he had gone out of his way to stop feeling that bad. And yeah, it seemed like their empathic bond had remained, which sent Katsuki on the edge. He sometimes would lie awake, waiting for the mirror of Deku's pain to appear and show him how much of a fuckup he was. Because he couldn't go too long without hurting Deku as a collateral damage, right?

The thought was uncharacteristically self-deprecating for him, but he couldn't help himself. He couldn't stop himself from thinking that this, being with Deku and being happy together, was just a short-term thing that wouldn't last for long. It wouldn't survive him, his moods, his temper, his angry tantrums, even if he was better now. Everything he touched turned to stone.

"I don't know", he said, melancholic. "Just thinking about how things have changed".

Izuku hummed.

"In what sense?"

Katsuki shrugged again. He didn't want to address the issue, but at the time he was desperate to put down some of the weight that was sitting on his chest.

"I didn't think I'd ever be… this. This close with someone. With anyone. With you, of all people", he admitted.

That seemed to be the wrong choice of words.

“Oh”, Deku said simply, sounding a bit taken aback.

Katsuki closed his eyes.

“I didn’t think you’d ever want this”, he clarified, hating how the honesty made his stomach churn.

He still found it difficult to talk to Deku about some subjects, to be so open and honest with him about his feelings – feelings that he, himself, had a hard time figuring out. It was a work in progress, as the rest of their relationship, but the self-deprecation in his tone still made him feel ashamed and vulnerable.

He hated feeling vulnerable. It was one of the feelings he despised the most, the one he had always ran away from all his life.

In fact, there is no true love without some level of vulnerability. But trust makes up for that.

He was starting to think Doctor Matsuo was some sort of telepath.

Izuku, however, chuckled.

“Are you serious?”, he asked with humor.

Katsuki grunted.

“Shuddup”, he said, humiliated.

“Kacchan, you’re everything I’ve always wanted”, Izuku said. “Ever since we were kids”.

Katsuki scoffed.

“Did you have a crush on me back then? That’s embarrassing”, he forced himself to joke, to provoke – mocking Deku was easier than acknowledging his feelings.

Izuku rolled his eyes.

“I wouldn’t say I had a crush. But I wanted you. As a friend. And now, I want you as more. What I’m saying is that the possibility of not loving you never even crossed my mind”.

Katsuki’s jaw tightened. He didn’t feel deserving of Deku’s blind adoration.

(How long until he ran out of that?)

“Not even when I told you to…?”, he trailed off.

“Told me to what?”, Izuku encouraged, still holding Katsuki close to his chest.

Katsuki sighed.

“You know. The rooftop thing”.

Silence.

“No”, Izuku said, sounding sincere. “I was upset, and I got angry because, if I really did do something, you’d be guilty of suicide ideation and it would ruin your career before it even started. But I didn’t stop *wanting* you”.

Katsuki laughed without humor, his tone dry and bitter. See? That was what he’d been on about. Deku clearly didn’t know what was best for himself. Katsuki had told him to kill himself, and yet he still loved him. He still put Katsuki’s necessities – his dream of becoming a pro – in front of his literal fucking *life*.

Katsuki was destined to have a dangerous career. Injury and death were just occupational hazards of his profession. And to know that Deku was so self-sacrificial that he wouldn’t hesitate to jump in front of Katsuki to save his life again – to know that he was so willing to lay down his own life for Katsuki’s sake – only made him feel *scared.*

Because he couldn’t afford to lose Deku again. *Not again*.

“I don’t know, Deku”, he admitted. “I don’t feel like that’s really healthy”.

Izuku froze, staring down at Katsuki.

“W-What?”

Katsuki sighed, tense. Ok, so they were going to have to talk about this.

“I was a dick to you”, he said. “I mistreated you. And I know we’ve talked about this and you said you forgave me for a lot of shit, but this? This is you telling me you forgave me long before I even *realized* I was sorry. Do you have no self-preservation at all? Why did you continue to love me when all I did was kick you when you were already down? Why do you *still* love me?”

Izuku was silent for a moment. Katsuki was breathing hard, but at the same time he couldn’t bring himself to break the hug they were sharing – just in case it was the last one they ever shared.

“Are you still the same person you were back in middle school?”, Izuku asked with simplicity.

Katsuki sagged against his hold.

He wasn’t. He definitely wasn’t.

“*No*”.

Izuku nodded.

“Neither am I. We both grew. Together, and individually. You’re not the same boy who told me to kill myself. I’m not the same boy who cowered beneath you. We’re both better than that, now”.

“But I’m talking about *back then*”, Katsuki insisted. “You said you loved me, but all I did was shove you around. I didn’t deserve your love back then. And I’m not so sure… if I already do”.

A pause.

“I’ve seen your worst”, Izuku said with a sad smile. “And I’ve seen your best. And I choose both. That’s what makes you, you. I don’t love you because of your mistakes. I love you despite them”, he shrugged as if it was all very simple.

Katsuki bit his inner cheeks. Could it? Be simple? Deku was willing to die for him, and Katsuki knew that no matter what he did, he couldn’t stop it – even if he pushed Deku away, even if he tried to hide his feelings, Deku would find a way to get into trouble. No matter what he did.

But could he really blame Deku? Hadn’t Katsuki sacrificed a lot for his sake as well? Wasn’t he, himself, willing to die if that would mean that Deku would get to live?

There was nothing healthy about that. But that couldn’t be changed, either – they had both seen each other die, and they were both scarred by that experience. Their souls were bound together – there was no walking away from it now. Separating wouldn’t mean the other’s life would be safer – it would mean they would have no one to watch their backs. They were stronger together. They were weaker apart. With or without a soulbond, they completed each other; it was as simple as the law of complementary colors.

Still… Katsuki felt like Deku’s universal forgiveness of him hadn’t been hard-earned. He wished they could find a middle ground between Deku forgiving his every action and Deku not speaking to him for half a year. Were the both of them up for that challenge of compromise?

“It’s rotten work”, Katsuki pointed out, giving Deku one last chance to hop off the messy boat that was Katsuki’s love for him.

“Not to me”, Izuku argued without missing a beat. “Not if it’s you”.

Katsuki lifted his head from where it was supported on Deku’s shoulder, finally staring him in the eye. Izuku stared back at him with nothing other than adoration in his eyes.

Katsuki closed his eyes. He didn’t feel deserving of that just yet, but it felt good. It *was* good, recovering, and growing, and being with Deku. Hugging him, cuddling him, caressing him. He felt like an addict who couldn’t get enough of it. He needed more. He wanted more.

He tenderly tilted his face closer to Deku’s, not breaking their hug. Deku aided him by crossing the other half of the distance that separated them. Their lips brushed, and Katsuki could feel Deku’s breath against his upper lip. The kiss was soft and simple, but it was meaningful. More than anything, it was a glimmer of hope in Katsuki’s blue horizon, turning it into green and red.

From: Best Friend

Ok

From: Best Friend

I figured it out

From: Best Friend

But I'm going to need your help

From: Shitty Hair

Didn't you say you wouldn't need help?

From: Best Friend

Shut up

From: Best Friend

I said I wouldn't need your help to plan it, I didn't say anything about executing the plan

From: Best Friend

Who did you tell?

From: Shitty Hair

Just the guys, but since Mina is included in that group, I'd say everyone sort of knows it by now

From: Best Friend

Good

From: Best Friend

By the way, what was Icy Hot's reaction?

From: Shitty Hair

Uh, I have no idea, I haven't spoken to him yet

From: Shitty Hair

Why do you ask?

From: Best Friend

No reason

From: Best Friend

Just wanted to see his face when he found out

From: Best Friend

What about Round Face?

From: Shitty Hair

What about her?

From: Best Friend

What was her reaction idiot

From: Shitty Hair

I don't know man, I didn't tell her, Mina did

From: Shitty Hair

Ask her, she should know

From: Shitty Hair

But what do you need my help with?? I'm curious

From: Best Friend

Well, now you're gonna have to wait while I talk to Mina

From: Shitty Hair

NOOOO

From: Bakubro

So, you know.

From: Raccoon Eyes

Know what, darling?

From: Bakubro

Stop joking around. I know Kirishima told you.

From: Raccoon Eyes

Told me what, dearest?

From: Bakubro

Cut this shit out.

From: Raccoon Eyes

What shit, beloved?

From: Bakubro

You suck.

From: Raccoon Eyes

Oh, I'M the one who sucks?

From: Raccoon Eyes

I've been texting you nonstop ever since I stepped out of that museum and you didn't reply to me ONCE. Not ONCE. I texted you every day asking for an update after you kicked everyone except for Midoriya out of your little hospital room. No reply. And you didn't even have the balls to tell me you were with Midoriya firsthand? You asked for someone else to do it for you?

From: Bakubro

I get it, you're pissed.

From: Raccoon Eyes

No, I WAS pissed

From: Raccoon Eyes

Now, I'm just in the mood to demand compensation, since you're obviously contacting me to ask for something

From: Bakubro

Fine, name your price

From: Raccoon Eyes

One photo of the two of you kissing

From: Bakubro

Bye

From: Raccoon Eyes

Ok, cuddling

From: Bakubro

I said bye

From: Raccoon Eyes

Fine, hugging! Final offer

From: Bakubro

Not happening

From: Bakubro

But I do have a better offer

From: Raccoon Eyes

I'm all ears

From: Bakubro

I'll ask you two questions and if you answer them, I'll let you help on my official first date with Deku

From: Bakubro

But you HAVE to keep the whole thing a secret or else I'm never speaking to you again

From: Raccoon Eyes

Ohhh, interesting

From: Raccoon Eyes

What are the questions?

From: Bakubro

I want to know how Round Face reacted when you (obviously) told her about me and Deku

From: Raccoon Eyes

Oh

From: Raccoon Eyes

Yeah, I can’t do that

From: Raccoon Eyes

Girl-to-girl confidentiality is unbreakable, sorry

From: Raccoon Eyes

Bras before bros

From: Bakubro

Fine, then. What about Icy Hot?

From: Raccoon Eyes

I didn’t tell him, Kaminari did

From: Bakubro

For FUCKS sake

From: Bakubro

Hold on

From: Shitty Hair

Duuuuuuude come back

From: Shitty Hair

Tell me what you need

From: Shitty Hair

I'm dying to know

Read at 21:13

From: Bakugou

So, everyone knows about it.

From: Dunce Face

Hello to you too after LITERALLY 27 IGNORED TEXTS

From: Dunce Face

I hate you I hope you know that

From: Dunce Face

I was DYING OF WORRY OK

From: Bakugou

Stop throwing a tantrum I was busy and recovering

From: Dunce Face

YEAH AND THAT DIDN'T STOP YOU FROM TEXTING MIDORIYA HUH

From: Bakugou

Oh my god shut the hell up

From: Dunce Face

YOU SHUT UP

From: Dunce Face

YOU WERE TEXTING KIRI TOO I KNOW IT

From: Dunce Face

Why am I the secondary friend :cc

From: Bakugou

You're not secondary, stop making this about you

From: Bakugou

And ok, sorry for not texting you back, that was a dick move

From: Bakugou

Now can you tell me how Icy Hot reacted when he learned about me and Deku kissing

From: Dunce Face

First of all you have no idea how HARD it was to keep that from everyone

From: Dunce Face

When Kiri told people I was so RELIEVED

From: Dunce Face

But I don't know what you want to know, Todoroki didn't really do anything?

From: Dunce Face

He just said "oh" and that was it

From: Bakugou

Pff. Pathetic

From: Bakugou

I should have known it

From: Dunce Face

But why do you ask?

From: Dunce Face

Oooooo I see

From: Dunce Face

You wanted to check if he was jelly, right?

From: Bakugou

I don't speak Stupid, you're gonna have to be clearer

From: Dunce Face

Jelly means jealous

From: Dunce Face

That's what you wanted to know, right??

From: Bakugou

…

From: Bakugou

Maybe

From: Dunce Face

Ahhhh Kacchan

From: Dunce Face

That's so cute!!

From: Bakugou

Who knew you'd be smart enough to realize that

From: Dunce Face

Oi, don't talk like that

From: Dunce Face

I don't know if he was jelly but I can try to find out 👀

From: Dunce Face

Do you want me to?

From: Bakugou

If your plan consists of walking up to him and asking him if he was jealous to his face, then no

From: Bakugou

If your plan is to find out discreetly about it, then yes

From: Dunce Face

I KNEW IT

From: Dunce Face

I’m on it Kacchan

From: Dunce Face

I’ll let you know when I find out 👀

From: Shitty Hair

Bakugou come baaaaaaack

From: Best Friend

Fine

From: Best Friend

I’m gonna tell you what I need now

From: Best Friend

But you HAVE to be discreet otherwise you’ll ruin everything and I’ll never forgive you

From: Shitty Hair

You got it, bro

From: Best Friend

Ok. First thing: talk to Mina and find out if Round Face was jealous of me and Deku or not.

From: Shitty Hair

Uh, WHAT?

From: Best Friend

Pikachu is checking to see if Icy Hot was jealous too

From: Best Friend

This isn’t just about my ego, if that’s what you’re thinking

From: Best Friend

I just want to make sure no one will try to sabotage the plan because they want my future boyfriend for themselves

From: Shitty Hair

Why would anyone try to sabotage you, you're our friend

From: Shitty Hair

But fine, go on

From: Best Friend

Ok, read it carefully because I won't repeat myself.

From: Best Friend

I need to know the answer about Icy Hot and Round Face first

From: Best Friend

Then:

Best Friend is typing…

Best Friend is typing…

Best Friend is typing…

"Have you told your mom?"

"Have I tol' he' wha'?", Izuku asked with a full mouth, chewing his dinner.

They were sitting together at UA's food court – it was late and they had missed dinner time, so they were the only ones there now. They had the whole saloon to themselves, and it felt a bit weird, sitting there without the background noise of different conversations and the rushed students walking by with lunch trays. Lucky for them, there had been some leftovers they could eat, and it took the kitchen lady one single look at Katsuki's cane to promise them she would heat the leftovers up so they could eat (even though that was kind of against the rules).

But yeah. Katsuki was wearing a cane now. Recovery Girl had insisted it would be temporary, and Katsuki sure hoped the old lady was right. He did feel a bit humiliated at the

beginning, but now he was getting used to it. He knew for a fact that walking with a cane neutralized the pain on his torso considerably and, even though it made him look like an old bastard, at least that allowed him to walk around without other people's help. He'd rather wear a cane than fall on his face in front of everyone because his knees buckled under the strain caused by his injury.

"About us, you dweeb", Katsuki rolled his eyes, poking at his dinner with his *hashi*. "About, you know. The kiss and all that".

"Oh", Izuku blinked. He seemed surprised at the thought – and surprised at the fact that it hadn't occurred to him yet. "No, I haven't told her… I – I should probably do that…", he said pensively, his eyes gaining that distant look on them that indicated Deku was about to start muttering his thoughts to himself.

Katsuki decided he could be a little bit of a dick, even if they were together now.

"Have you told *All Might*?", he teased, raising one eyebrow.

Izuku's eyes widened mid-ramble and he blushed.

"N-No! I haven't either… Oh my god… How could I forget about that…", he started muttering again. "I should… But how can I… I don't know how he'll…"

"Relax", Katsuki rolled his eyes. "He kept a lot of secrets from the both of us. It's only fair you keep some secrets from him in return".

Izuku blinked at Katsuki.

"Did you… tell your parents?", he asked, sounding nervous. Katsuki shrugged and huffed through his nose.

"They don't care about this sort of shit", he said, grabbing a bite of his lukewarm dinner.

Izuku frowned.

"How do you know?"

"They never asked me about it", he said simply, chewing a mouthful of food. "They pro'lly know my career as a pro doesn' leave much space for romance, so they'll be happy with whatever they can get".

Izuku gave him a look. He nudged Katsuki's leg lightly with his foot beneath the table.

"Is that what I am to them?", he raised a curious eyebrow. "The second-best option to having you die old and alone?"

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

"You know what I meant", he said. "They probably thought I was going to dedicate myself to my career and never start a family. We both know I ain't exactly the romantic type", Katsuki

gestured at himself. “So I don’t know. I guess they’ll be happy it’s you. At least you’re not a total stranger”.

Izuku smiled softly at him, watching him with tender eyes.

“Really?”, he asked.

Katsuki shrugged, focused on his dinner.

“Really”, he said simply, biting down another mouthful. “Can’t say the same about your old woman, though”.

Izuku looked away.

“I… talked to her about this. Before UA and One For All”, Izuku said. “I mean, starting a family and girls and boys and all that. I…”, he bit his lower lip. “I never thought too much about it, either. I mean, I had a whole different life before UA. I only got One For All on the day of the admission exam. Before that, all I was… All I was, was a stupid little quirkless boy with no muscles and no plans. I wanted to become a hero so badly, I didn’t look at anything past that. Not even… romance”.

Katsuki watched him, and then he nodded.

“Don’t you go thinking that just because we kissed you’re gonna get rid of me as your rival”, Katsuki said pointedly, continuing to eat. “I’m still gonna beat your ass and become number one”, he said, giving Deku a look just to check if he was listening.

Deku smiled and tilted his chin up defiantly.

“I can tell you the same”, he said with determination. “We can both train together and push each other to our limits”.

“Yeah, we’d know something about pushing each other and limits”, Katsuki snorted, earning a tiny laugh from Izuku.

“But are your parents ok with…”, Izuku tried. “Uh, you know. The fact that I’m a boy, and all that?”

Katsuki shrugged again, unbothered.

“Like I said, I don’t think they give a crap. And if they do, that’s their problem. It’s not like they can tell me what to do and who to date”.

Izuku nodded nervously, lowering his gaze. Something about his pensive stance made Katsuki narrow his eyes.

“Why, you think your mom will care I’m not a girl?”, Katsuki frowned. He knew how precious Inko was to Deku, and how her opinion mattered to him.

“No, no!”, Izuku said, eyes widening and shaking his head vehemently. “Like I said, I talked to her about this. I made it clear that I didn’t like only girls, so I’m guessing she understood the message… And she’s always supported me. I think… I think she’d be happy I’m dating *someone*”.

“Oh, so that’s what I am?”, Katsuki raised a teasing eyebrow, mimicking Deku’s speech from before. “Just ‘*someone”*?”

Izuku rolled his eyes.

“Idiot”.

“Shitface”.

“Hey!”

“What? You started it”.

Izuku rolled his eyes again. They fell in comfortable silence, and continued to eat.

It took a while for one of them to speak up again.

“So what are you doing tomorrow?”, Katsuki asked conversationally.

Izuku frowned, thinking.

“Uh… What day is tomorrow again?”

“Saturday”, Katsuki provided.

“Oh”, Izuku nodded. “I don’t think I have anything to do. Maybe study a bit after class, and train with All Might. Other than that, I’m free”.

Katsuki nodded. He continued to eat with one hand, but grabbed his phone with the other.

From: Best Friend

So?

From: Shitty Hair

As far as I recall my quirk doesn’t involve super speed

From: Best Friend

For fuck’s sake Kirishima

“Is everything ok?”, Izuku asked with a hint of a frown when he noticed Katsuki was scowling at his phone. “You’ve been typing in your phone a lot”.

“Yeah”, Katsuki said, locking the phone screen and setting it back in his pocket. “Just Kirishima being an asshole”.

“Oh”, Izuku said, taking a sip of his drink. “Well, I’m sure he’s just worried about you”.

“Nothing to be worried about”, Katsuki rolled his eyes. “I’m getting better. But anyway”, he shrugged, going back to eating.

“Did you…”, Izuku said, a bit awkward. Katsuki looked at him. “… You know. Tell him?”

Katsuki raised his eyebrows.

“About the kiss?”

Izuku nodded.

“Yeah”, Katsuki huffed. “He knows. Well – Everyone knows, probably”.

Izuku stared at him.

“W-What?”

Katsuki stared back at Izuku, confused.

“Uh, I told him it was ok to tell people”, Katsuki said, his stomach twitching. “Don’t you remember I asked you about it?”

Izuku blinked blankly, lowering his head for a moment. He thought for a bit before responding.

“I guess I thought I had dreamed that interaction”, he admitted.

Katsuki lowered his *hashi*, staring at Izuku with a worried look. Before he could say anything, the nerd added:

“I mean, I’m not ashamed or anything, and I had… I had spoken to Kaminari-kun about it. Because, you know, he saw it and everything. And he and I made an agreement to keep it a secret for a while, because well. I didn’t know how you’d feel about the kiss, or if you’d want anyone to know. And I’m”, he smiled, “I’m really happy you felt comfortable with everyone learning about it”.

Katsuki smiled back at him tentatively, taking a sip of his own drink.

“Of course I’m fucking comfortable”, he said after he swallowed. “I don’t give a crap what these extras will think about me, or about us”, he added, even though he was dying to learn about Icy Hot’s and Round Face’s reactions. He supposed that, in a way, he had always seen them as rivals when it came to Deku’s attention, and now that they were together, he knew that there must be some hard feelings involved.

Katsuki’s phone vibrated, so he fished it out of his pocket again.

From: Dunce Face

Ok, so Todoroki is surprisingly… cool about this

From: Dunce Face

Haha get it?

From: Dunce Face

But I do think he’ll want to speak to you about it, if I understood him correctly

From: Bakugou

Speak to me? About what?

From: Dunce Face

I don’t know but I would guess that this is something about protecting Midoriya as a friend

From: Dunce Face

I don’t know… He’s always so stoic that it’s hard to read his feelings

From: Dunce Face

So I really don’t know. Good luck?

Katsuki huffed.

From: Bakugou

I won't need luck.

From: Best Friend

Any news?

From: Shitty Hair

Duuuuude you gotta be more patient with me

Katsuki huffed another breath and put his phone away.

"I hadn't really thought about all this until you mentioned it…", Izuku said pensively when he saw that Katsuki's attention was no longer on his phone. "But I think I really need to tell my mom".

Katsuki stared at him.

"I think you should wait a bit", he suggested.

Izuku frowned.

"Wait?"

"Yeah", Katsuki shrugged. "This is all too… sudden? The museum shit is still all over the news. Maybe give her some time to digest the fact that you just survived a terrorist attack before you dump the gay bomb on her".

Izuku chuckled. He tried to cover his mouth from view as he did, which Katsuki found surprisingly endearing.

"Is that what we are, huh?", he raised his eyebrows.

"What? Gay?", Katsuki frowned. "I don't know. I didn't have one big gay awakening out of nowhere, I just… Happened to realize I really liked having you around".

Izuku tilted his head a bit to the side, like he did when he was confused.

"Seriously?", he blinked, narrowing his eyes a little as if he didn't quite believe Katsuki.

"Yeah", Katsuki shrugged. "Why?"

Izuku blushed. He averted his eyes from Katsuki's face, staring at anything but him.

“I don’t… I don’t think I ever thought too much about it”, Izuku said. “Like I said, I was too busy dreaming about being a hero, even though I was quirkless. But… After I got into UA, and I met Uraraka-san, and Hatsume-san…”

It was Katsuki’s time to narrow his eyes. Something about what Deku was saying sent a hint of possessiveness through his chest, but he tried to keep the jealousy at bay.

“And, I mean, before them, and before Asui-san, and Mina-san, and Kyouka-san, and all the girls from our class… I had never *ever* spoken to a girl. And, other than you, I had never really had a friend like Iida-kun or Todoroki-kun. So UA was the first place, and the first time in my life, when I actually started to… figure out who I really was. Who I wanted to be”.

Katsuki continued to watch him.

“And who are you?”

Izuku tilted his chin up.

“I’m Midoriya Izuku”, he said. “I don’t think I’m gay, but I’m definitely not straight. And I don’t think it really matters who I had a crush on, or who I thought I had a crush on, because the first person I loved, the person who I’ve always loved, is sitting right in front of me”.

Katsuki felt a victorious grin spread on his face.

“Damn right”, he said, cocky.

Izuku chuckled again.

“You’re supposed to say you love me back, you know”.

“Do I need to keep repeating it?”, Katsuki raised an eyebrow.

Izuku hesitated.

“Not if you don’t want to”, he shrugged, barely managing to hide his disappointment. “But I do like to hear it”.

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“You’re a stupid nerd, but a stupid nerd that I love”, he said.

Izuku smiled widely.

Katsuki’s phone vibrated again.

From: Shitty Hair

Ok so if I got everything right, Uraraka is ok but she wants to talk to Midoriya about it

From: Shitty Hair

Apparently, she, Iida and Todoroki have been texting him like crazy but he never responded

Katsuki looked up at Izuku.

“Oi, nerd. Where’s your phone?”, he asked.

Izuku frowned. He shifted on his seat to reach for his pocket, but, after palming the right one, and then the left one, he looked up at Katsuki with a frown.

“I don’t have it on me”, he announced. “It must have stayed back at your room”.

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“Your stupid friends are trying to talk to you”, he relayed the message. “But you’re not answering them”.

“Oh”, Izuku blinked, blushing. “Oh, ok. When we get back, I can stop by your room and grab it”.

Katsuki frowned.

“So you won’t be staying?”, he asked.

Izuku blushed harder.

“W-Well, I assumed that if they want to talk to me, it would be in – in p-person”, he justified. “I’m also assuming they’ll want to talk about – uh, well. Us. They must have, uh. Heard about the kiss, and all that”.

Katsuki nodded.

“So that will probably take a while”, Izuku added.

Katsuki sighed and shrugged.

“Fine. Suit yourself”.

Izuku frowned.

“Will you be…?”

“What?”

“… Upset?”, Izuku questioned.

Katsuki shook his head.

“No. I think you should talk to your friends. And take the chance to create some fucking boundaries while you’re at it”, he added with a pointed look.

Izuku scratched the back of his head.

“I don’t think I’ll have to”, he pointed out. “I mean, they’re not as teasing as Kirishima-kun and Kaminari-kun and Sero-kun”.

Katsuki huffed.

“Yeah, guess you’re right. But both Icy Hot and Round Face have the hots for you, so I wouldn’t be surprised if they wanted to trash-talk me. I don’t know about Four Eyes, but I’ll keep an eye on him”.

Izuku’s eyes widened and his face became as red as a tomato.

“W-W-What? K-Kacchan, what are you talking about?!”, he exclaimed.

Katsuki simply rolled his eyes.

“Oh, come on. Don’t act like you didn’t know it”, he reprimanded.

Izuku put down his *hashi* and took a very long sip of his drink, trying to calm himself down.

“T-They d-don’t – they couldn’t – I don’t – what are you – I mean, I don’t – I wouldn’t – I –“

“Stop stuttering”, Katsuki sighed at him.

“Well, I don’t know what to tell you!”, Izuku tried to defend himself.

“You don’t have to *tell* me anything. What you should do is start thinking about what you’ll tell *them*”.

Izuku rubbed a hand on his mortified face, looking anguished.

“I mean – how do you even know that? Did they tell you anything? Did they – Did they –“

“They didn’t tell me anything”, Katsuki said with a grumpy face. “But I do have eyes, as opposed to you, apparently. Their crush on you was pretty obvious”.

Izuku frowned, offended.

“No, it wasn’t!”

“Yes, it was”, he eyerolled again.

“Stop!”, Izuku asked. “Really, just… *stop*. I really don’t think they like me that way”.

“Well, I wouldn’t risk it”, Katsuki scoffed. “The only thing I like more than competition is when I *defeat* my competition”.

Izuku narrowed his eyes at him, his face going back to a normal expression.

“Oh”, he said simply, to which Katsuki frowned.

“*What*?”, he asked, sounding bothered.

Izuku huffed out a little amused breath, as if he had just realized something. He leaned back against his seat’s rest and crossed his arms above his chest.

“I see”, he commented simply, full of himself.

Katsuki twisted his nose, annoyed by all the mystery.

“See *what*?”

“This isn’t about them, is it?”, Izuku raised his eyebrows. “This is about *you*”.

Katsuki stared at him.

“You’re gonna elaborate, or…?”

Izuku smiled, seeming pleased with himself.

“You’re only seeing them as competition because you’re *jealous* of me”.

Katsuki’s face turned into a scowl.

“I see them as competition because that’s what they *are*”, he retorted.

Izuku smiled.

“Kacchan”, he said patiently. “There’s nothing wrong with being jealous!”

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“There’s also nothing wrong with you telling your extra friends that I’m the only one allowed anywhere near that trashmouth of yours, unless they want to meet an early demise”.

Izuku chuckled at this, dimples appearing on his cheeks. He seemed entertained.

“You get cute when you’re jealous”, he commented, which made Katsuki sigh.

“I’m not *cute*”, he defended himself. “I’m deadly”.

“All right, deadly man”, Izuku said. “Are you done with dinner?”

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“Yeah. We can try to show up on time tomorrow and eat some actually fresh food instead of this microwaved crap”.

“Don’t talk like that”, Izuku reprimanded, standing up from his seat and grabbing both of their trays. “That lady was really nice to us, letting us eat past curfew”.

Katsuki sighed, but didn’t say anything. Izuku discarded the trays, then he returned to Katsuki’s side.

“So, I’ll go back with you to grab my phone, then I’ll go talk to my friends”, Izuku said. “Is that ok?”

“You don’t need my permission”, Katsuki said with a huff, standing up after denying Izuku’s help and leaning his weight on the cane.

“I wasn’t asking for your permission”, Izuku pointed out. “I just wanted to know if you’ll be upset if I tell them what happened between us. Especially since you’re jealous of most of my friend group”.

“Well, it’s like you said”, Katsuki shrugged. “Kissing me is something to boast about, not to keep a secret”.

Izuku blushed, and tilted his face to try and hide it.

“I do think I’ll tell my mom”, he said pensively, in a more serious tone.

Katsuki sighed.

“Suit yourself”, he said simply. “If you think she should know, then tell her. I’m sure she’ll support you no matter what you say to her”.

Izuku smiled softly.

“Yeah…”, he said hesitantly, as if he wasn’t so sure of himself when it came to this conversation.

He didn’t seem very worried, but he wasn’t completely comfortable either. Katsuki didn’t know whether he should push him into talking or leaving the subject altogether, which was why he found himself saying:

“Will you stop by after you’re done?”, he asked, putting a special effort on not sounding too clingy.

Izuku looked at him.

“Oh. I thought you’d be asleep?”

“So what? Just sneak in and sleep with me”, Katsuki shrugged easily.

Izuku blinked.

“But you keep your door locked”, he pointed out.

Katsuki sighed.

“If you don’t want to, just spit it out. Stop making up excuses”, he reprimanded.

“Kacchan”, Izuku groaned. “Of course I *want* to”.

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“Whatever. Better if you stay in your room, now that I think about it. I don’t want your hyperactive ass waking me up”.

Izuku raised his eyebrows.

“Oh, so you’re kicking me out?”, he asked, teasing evident in his tone.

“Yeah”.

“That’s mean, Kacchan”.

“Thought you were used to it”, Katsuki teased back.

“Well, just because I’m used to it doesn’t mean you should do it”.

“As I always say to you: don’t tell me what to do”.

Izuku rolled his eyes.

“Classic Kacchan”.

They walked the rest of the way in silence and arrived quickly at Katsuki’s bedroom, even though the explosive boy had to walk a bit more slowly because of his recovering injury and his cane. They stopped by the door to his room, and Izuku turned to him with shining eyes.

“If you really want me to come sleep with you, I will”, he said, taking Katsuki’s free hand into his own.

Katsuki rolled his eyes, placing a tender kiss on Izuku’s forehead.

“I’ll be fine. Take your time talking to your shitty, noisy friends and we’ll see each other on Sunday”.

Izuku frowned.

“On *Sunday*? Not tomorrow?”

Katsuki shrugged.

“I have shit to do tomorrow”.

Izuku narrowed his eyes at him, suspicious.

“What *shit*?”

“You kiss your mother with that mouth?”

“Kacchan”.

Katsuki sighed.

“It’s not a big deal. I have physical therapy. My scheduled weekly appointment with Recovery Girl. Lots of study to do”.

Izuku continued to frown, pouting a little and starting to resemble a bit a spoiled child.

“Oh… Ok…”, he said, clearly disappointed.

Katsuki rolled his eyes, using his free hand to pull Izuku close to himself. The boy nestled his head on the crook of his neck.

“You’ll survive one single day without my magnificent presence”.

Izuku rolled his eyes, but didn’t pull away from the hug.

“Can I come sleep with you tomorrow, then?”, he inquired.

Katsuki thought for a moment.

“Yeah, sure”, he shrugged.

He felt Izuku smile against his shoulder. The boy finally stepped back from the hug, but he continued to hold Katsuki’s hand into his own.

“Don’t forget to take your medicine”, he advised.

Katsuki sighed.

“Even if I wanted to, I have around five different people reminding me of it”.

Izuku nodded.

“Good”.

“Ok”.

They stared at each other in silence. A few moments passed.

“All right”, Izuku said finally, letting go of Katsuki’s hand and taking a step back. “I’ll go see if the guys are at the common room”.

“Deku”, Katsuki called as he started to walk away.

“Huh?”

Katsuki raised one eyebrow.

“Aren’t you forgetting something?”

Izuku frowned, then he walked back to Katsuki. He closed his eyes and leaned in for a kiss. Katsuki rolled his eyes and kissed him back, eagerly, momentarily forgetting that any of their friends could walk by at any given minute and find them in the middle of the act.

When Izuku pulled back and smiled at him, ready to take off again, Katsuki grabbed the front of his shirt to keep him in place.

“Your *phone*, idiot”, he said, letting go of Izuku and turning to unlock the door.

“Oh, right, that”, Izuku chuckled, clearly embarrassed. “I had totally forgotten about that”.

“I know you did”, Katsuki scoffed, entering his room. He limped towards his bed and searched for the device amidst all his pillows, finding it buried beneath the ones Deku had been clinging to. He turned on his heels, his cane tapping loudly on the floor, before he handed the phone to Deku. “Here. Try not to lose it again”.

Deku smiled, taking the phone and looking at the screen.

His face fell.

“Uh oh”, he said. “127 new texts and 8 missed calls”.

Katsuki gave him an amused look.

“You’re friends with some clingy fucking bastards”, he scoffed.

Deku stared up at him with a grimace.

“I really should go”, he said, backing off towards the door and turning on his heels in a mid-jog. “Don’t forget to take your meds!”, he shouted after himself, disappearing through the corridor.

Katsuki rolled his eyes affectionately. Since Deku had left the door wide open, he was forced to march his way back to it in order to close it.

He considered leaving the door unlocked in the scarce hope that Deku would come back after he was done chatting with his annoying friends and lie down on the bed with him. But then, he remembered his plan. He remembered his agreement with Kirishima.

He locked the door and walked back to the bed, sitting down. He swallowed down his medication and lied back in the clothes he was wearing, feeling tired. He didn’t want to admit it to anyone – not even to Deku –, but he was still getting tired more often from doing simple tasks. Recovery Girl had said that this would happen for a while, until he was 100% better, but it didn’t make Katsuki feel less like a weakling because of it.

He sighed and closed his eyes. Sleep ended up claiming him in a matter of minutes.

"Absolutely not".

Katsuki sighed and gave Aizawa sensei a look.

"I'm not asking for much –"

"Yes, you are", he interrupted.

Katsuki narrowed his eyes.

"No, I'm not", he pointed out. "I'm cleared out of the hospital –"

"Barely".

"— and I'm recovering well –"

"Let's keep it that way".

"And it won't take more than *half an hour*!", he half-shouted, annoyed by the constant interruption.

"The answer is still no", Aizawa sensei said stoically, giving his student an impassive look.

Katsuki sighed out a heavy breath and took a step back, hating that he had to bring the cane along to the teachers' room. It was obvious that the cane's presence wasn't helping out his case, but he had assumed that using it would be better than ending up collapsing because he lacked its support.

"Come on", he said, his tone very close to begging – which made him feel ashamed of himself. "You can ask someone to accompany me like you did when Deku was a ghost –"

"That was an unusual situation", Aizawa pointed out.

"Well, it's not like the *current* situation is any usual!", Katsuki gestured at his cane.

Aizawa sensei continued to stare at him without any resemblance of interest.

“Bakugou. You were the target of two different villain attacks. You were gravely injured and almost died. I don’t need to remind you of all the reasons why I can’t let you out of the school for no good reason”.

“It *is* a good reason”, he tried, but deep down he knew the battle was lost.

“My answer is no”, Aizawa said firmly. “And you can stay there and whine all you want for as long as you want, and the answer will still be no. So why don’t you go do something more useful with your time while you’re still cleared out of school duty?”

Katsuki bit his inner cheeks and lowered his head, angry. There were a lot of angry retorts he wanted to give his teacher, and all of them included brand-new swear words.

However, the man was right. No matter what Katsuki said, he wouldn’t be allowed to go out of UA unless his parents came and picked him up as if he was a preschooler. That would be his fate until he was 100% recovered from his injury.

“You know what? Fine”, he scoffed, using his spare hand to reach for his ears and remove his hearing aids. Aizawa sensei raised an amused eyebrow.

“*Is that your petty attempt to show you literally won’t listen to me?”*, Aizawa signed at him with his hands.

Katsuki narrowed his eyes.

“*I didn’t know you knew sign language*”, he signed back.

Aizawa sighed and gave him a tired look.

“*I’m a hero and a teacher. Of course I know sign language*”.

Katsuki huffed a partially amused breath.

Still upset by his teacher’s denial, he turned on his heels and marched out of the room without another word, his cane tapping loudly on the floor. He could only hear the phantom echo of the tap-tap-tap without his aids on, but Katsuki fucking hated that noise, so he started to walk faster in order to reach his room at once and throw the damned thing at its farthest corner.

He miraculously managed to get back to his room without being stopped by anyone, but that was probably because his friends were attending to class. Plus, even if someone did call him at some point along the way, he wouldn’t have been able to hear it and respond without his aids on.

Katsuki had a medical leave, since he was still recovering and attending physical therapy, which was at the same time as his early morning classes. He had insisted that he could – and should – attend whichever classes didn’t collide with his therapy schedule, but Recovery Girl had been firm: he didn’t have to stay at the medbay all the time anymore, but that didn’t clear him out to do whatever he wanted. Mostly, he needed to take the free time to rest and recover, and his teachers – Aizawa sensei included – would understand his absence.

He entered his room with tiredness and decided that, as much as he hated the cane, throwing it across the room would cause more trouble than it was worth. He'd have to bend down and pick it up when he had to go out again, and the movement would cause him unnecessary pain. Because of this, he placed the cane near the bed and flopped down on it, lying back and taking in the pleasant feeling of *resting*.

He stared at the ceiling for a moment, trying to think of what to do. Not being able to leave UA was a big hindrance on not one, but four steps of his first-date-with-Deku plans. Which meant he would have to find a way around the shitty obstacles if he really wanted to do this.

First, the easy fix. He texted Kirishima. The boy was in class, but he could read the messages later.

From: Best Friend

So, remember my carefully crafted plan of taking Deku back to the same place you guys threw me that shitty birthday party and surprising him with a romantic picnic for a first date?

From: Best Friend

You know, the symbolic plan which was meant to represent the end of the hostility between us and the growth and acceptance we both went through despite all our fights and arguments. The one where you'd all trick him into going there and then he'd get all teary-eyed when he saw me waiting for him, sitting on the grass under the sakura trees with his favorite snacks?

From: Best Friend

Turns out Aizawa sensei took a huge dump on it and buried it on the ground. AKA: it's not happening.

From: Best Friend

Apparently I can't leave UA until I'm 100% better. So we're going to have to adapt.

From: Best Friend

Come here after class so we can discuss my new idea.

Ok, first step: solved. Now there were only three more steps to figure out. Two of them were dreadful, but he decided to start out with the second hardest one.

After putting his hearing aids back on, he dialed the number on his phone and hit the call button. It rang once, twice, three times, before his mom picked up.

“Hey, brat”, she greeted, sounding more lively than usual. As if she was happy to talk to him, or something like that.

“Hey”, Katsuki greeted back. Then, straight to the point: “I need a favor”.

There was a pause.

“Oh?”, Mitsuki said, surprised. “You don’t usually ask for favors”.

Katsuki grinded his teeth, irritated. The reason why he didn’t usually ask for favors was because he hated when people shoved it on his *face*, like she was doing right now.

“Don’t make me regret this, old hag”, he said with a warning.

His mom just laughed in response.

“All right, all right, I keep forgetting how *proud* you are. Just spit it out, kiddo”.

Katsuki took a deep breath.

“I need you to go to the mall and buy something for me. I’ll give you the name of the store and the name of the clerk I talked to – he’s keeping the item I want in stock for me. I can give you the money when you bring it to me here at UA today. I’d go and buy it myself, but the fucking teachers won’t let me out of school grounds until I’m fully recovered”.

“Ok”, his mom said, compliant. “What do you need me to buy?”

Katsuki closed his eyes. He was tempted to tell his mom to just grab the item with the clerk and trust it to be the right one without checking it before she paid for it, but he didn’t want to risk the possibility she would buy the wrong thing and ruin his plans.

He didn’t want his *mom* to know about it either, but he figured she would have to know at some point. It was inevitable.

He took a deep breath.

“It’s a limited edition of ‘All Might: your soulmate valentine’ pair of necklaces”, he said, shame and embarrassment burning in his stomach.

There was a pause.

“A… *what*?”, Mitsuki said, and it was obvious that she was trying not to laugh. Katsuki felt angry, even though he had predicted this sort of reaction.

“Just buy the damn thing and bring it over to me!”, he snapped through gritted teeth. “And don’t you *dare* speak one word of this to anyone”.

“Who would I even tell? One of your two friends?”, Mitsuki said, humor in her voice. Katsuki huffed.

“Shut up. I’m never asking you for a favor ever again”.

“Oh, don’t be such a baby, Katsuki”, she reprimanded. “But are you going to tell me who this valentine necklace is for or do I have to guess?”

“It’s none of your business”, Katsuki said out of instinct, before he could think better about it.

“Is it for Kirishima?”

That felt like a slap to his face.

“*What?*”

“Oh, come on. You’ve never, *ever* looked at a girl twice in your short life, but you did introduce Kirishima to us. I thought this was your way to be subtle about it. Well… I mean, I *had* thought that until you asked me to buy your valentine a *gift,* which is as subtle as that big gay elephant in the room”.

“It’s not fucking *Kirishima*, old hag”, Katsuki said, not knowing why the hell his mom had thought that in the first place. “What – You thought that just because I introduced him to you, I was dating him?!”, he asked, almost offended.

“You’re the one who’s all mysterious about this shit, don’t blame me for making a wrong guess!”, she retorted. “If it’s not Kirishima, then who it is?”

Katsuki’s nostrils flared with anger.

“I’d tell you to make a guess, but if you honestly think I’d date Kirishima, it’s obvious you’ll never guess it right”.

“Do you want the damn necklace or not?”, she threatened.

Katsuki sighed. He wanted to tell his mom to go fuck herself, but it wasn’t like he had a plethora of people available to go to the mall for him. In for a penny, in for a pound.

“It’s Deku”, he said shortly, his face very serious. *She’d have to know at some point. She’d have to know.*

Silence.

More silence.

“Are you still there?”, Katsuki frowned.

“*Midoriya?*”, she exclaimed so loudly that Katsuki hoped she was at home – if she was yelling about his relationship in the middle of the street or at work, Katsuki would kill her.

“Yes, that’s him, now can you go buy the godforsaken necklace or *what*”, he spat.

“But – wait a minute – I get that he saved your life and all, but… You hated him. Didn’t you? I’m not remembering it wrong, am I?”, she asked, clearly confused.

“Yeah, I used to hate him, and now I don’t hate him anymore, what is it to you?”, he said, feeling like a child throwing a tantrum. In his defense, his mom’s excited reaction wasn’t doing his already sour mood any favors, so he wasn’t really to blame here.

“How do you go from hating someone to giving them an All Might whatever-whatever valentine necklace?”, she inquired. Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“You get soulbound to them and find out that your mixed feelings of hatred and anger were actually misplaced concern and vulnerability”, Katsuki said. “I’m going to call the store and tell them that you’re going to get the necklace in my place. It’s limited edition, so for fuck’s sake, don’t get sidetracked or they might sell it to someone else”.

“I won’t”, Mitsuki provided. “When is your date with Midoriya?”

“*What* date?”, Katsuki asked, annoyed at his mom for making assumptions – even though the assumption was right.

“Well, if you’re going to gift him with the valentine necklace, you have to do it on a date”, she provided. “I know you’re even less romantic than I am, but even *I* know that”.

Katsuki huffed.

“The date will happen soon. I need the damn necklace first”.

“See! I knew there was a date!”, she celebrated. “Why do you have to be so mysterious about everything? Tell your old woman about your love life!”

“I literally would rather die. And I can say that, because I’ve been there”, he scoffed.

There was an awkward pause.

“Don’t joke about that”, Mitsuki reprimanded, sounding suddenly sober. “What a way to kill such a nice conversation”.

“I’m glad you were having such a great time learning about my thing with Deku, but I need my damn necklace. Will you bring it to me?”

Mitsuki sighed.

“Fine, brat. I’ll bring your damn necklace”.

“Good”.

“Today?”

“Well, yeah”.

“Is the date tomorrow?”

“*Mom*”, he growled.

“Fine, fine, I’ll stop asking about it. But if it wasn’t for the necklace thing, when were you going to tell me about him?”

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“I don’t know. Eventually”.

“*Eventually?*”

“Yeah”.

“Well, I guess that I’ll bring you your damn necklace *eventually*, too”.

“Oh, fuck off”, Katsuki huffed. “It’s not like you ever cared for this sort of thing”.

“Well, I never cared because *you* never cared”, Mitsuki pointed out. “Now that my baby is growing up, I want to know everything!”

Katsuki sighed.

“I should have asked dad instead”, he complained, half-hearted.

“Oh, come on. You know that if you had asked your dad, you’d never hear the end of it”.

“Well, at least he’d go to the damn mall faster!”

“All right, all right! Jeez, you’re way too demanding for someone who’s asking a *favor*”.

Katsuki took a deep calming breath, irritated. There she was, throwing it at his face again.

But he really needed the damn necklace. The sooner the better. And she was right: if he had asked his dad, he’d get tears and sobbing in response. Katsuki couldn’t really stand that, so his mom was his best option right now. He didn’t really trust anyone else in his close circle to do it properly.

“Fine. Sorry”, he said in spite of himself, angry and reluctant. *These feel like Doc Matsuo’s words instead of my own.*

Are they my own?

A pause.

“I see therapy’s doing wonders for your manners”, Mitsuki teased.

Katsuki sighed.

“Bye, mom”.

“Oh, come on, kiddo! I thought you could take a teasing!”, she joked. “Fine, I’ll stop mocking around. I’ll go to the store get your damn necklace”.

“Fine”.

“Good. Need anything else?”, she offered.

“No”, Katsuki said shortly.

“And how are you?”, she asked, sounding genuinely interested.

“I’m fine”, Katsuki said. “Getting better each day”.

“You’re not skipping your appointments with that tiny old woman, are you?”, he could basically see the suspicious squint his mother must have given her phone as she said that.

Katsuki sighed again.

“*No,* mom”, he said vehemently. “I’m going to the damn appointments”.

“Good”, Mitsuki said. “I’m just asking because I know what you’re like. You think people will look down on you if you need help, even though you were literally impaled –“

“You know what, I’m hanging up”, Katsuki interrupted her. His patience was bigger now that he went to therapy, but even that had a limit. “Bye”.

“Katsuki –“

He didn’t hear the end of it. With a tap on his screen, he ended the call.

Ok. Two more calls to go. If the walk to Aizawa sensei’s office and back to the dorm hadn’t made him tired, talking to his mom had. He was already dying for a nap, and it was almost time to take his medicine.

Still, before he allowed himself to finally get some rest, he called the All Might official store at the mall and explained that he wouldn’t be able to go fetch the necklace himself, but that his mother Mitsuki would go in his place. The clerk was nice and told him he would safekeep the necklace for him even though it was the last one at that store and several people had come looking for it. Katsuki was feeling very grateful for that, until the guy decided to tell him that he hoped “your lucky girl likes it!”

“Actually, it’s for a lucky *boy*”, Katsuki corrected the man. “But thanks”.

He hung up before the man could reply.

Which left him with the final call to make. If he really wanted to have this first date with Deku, and if he really wanted it to go right, there was one last person he needed to contact.

Well, see: he didn't *need* to contact this person. It wasn't mandatory. But Katsuki hadn't been raised by animals, he knew the basic steps of courtship. He knew that, if he wanted to do things right, he needed to follow certain steps.

So he searched for the contact name on his phone and hit dial.

The reply was almost immediate.

"Hello?"

"Hey", he said, feeling a bit nervous – which was so unlike his usual strong façade that it made him feel nauseous. Was he a person who got nervous with this sort of dating-life now?

"Katsuki-kun", Inko said, seeming surprised. "How nice of you to call".

"I wanted – uh, needed – to talk to you", he said, tense.

"Of course, dear", Inko replied. "Is everything all right?"

"Yeah", he swallowed dry. "I'm – still recovering from what happened at the museum. Which is why I'm calling in the first place. I'd rather go down to your house and have this talk in person, but the school won't let me leave until I'm fully recovered".

"Oh, I see", Inko said, comprehensive. "And how is recovery going?"

"It's going well", he said. "Just not well enough for me to leave just yet. I was wondering… Would you be able to come to the school so we could talk?"

There was a pause. Inko seemed pensive.

"You sound very serious", she commented. "What's the matter?"

"It's nothing urgent", Katsuki tried to ease her. "And it's not what you're thinking. It's just – something important. About Deku. Something I wanted to talk to you about".

"About Izuku?", she asked, concerned. Katsuki could picture the frown on her face. "What is it?"

He sighed, trying to muster what was left of his patience.

"Like I said, nothing urgent", he said. "And you don't have to worry about him, he's fine. It's – It's more about me than it is about him".

There was another pause.

"I don't think I understand, dear. Why can't you tell me over the phone?"

Katsuki closed his eyes, counting to ten in his head and taking a series of deep breaths.

"Look", he said as patiently as he currently could. "Just come over. We can talk then , ok?"

“O-Ok”, Inko said, clearly worried. “I’ll go to the school as soon as I can”.

“Can you make it today?”, he proposed.

“T-Today?”, Inko said, hesitant. “Oh, dear… I hadn’t… I don’t have anything ready… I…”

“Good”, Katsuki said, as if she had just answered his question. “I have to go now”.

“A-All right”, Inko agreed, still sounding tense. “I’ll try to go over today. Bye, Katsuki-kun”.

“Oh, one more thing”, Katsuki remembered. “Don’t tell Deku I called you and asked you to come here”.

A pause.

“Why not?”

Katsuki bit his inner cheeks.

“It has to do with a surprise”, he said. “I don’t want to spoil it”.

“Oh”, Inko said, sounding a bit relieved. “Ok, I’ll be discreet”.

“Thanks”.

“You’re welcome, dear. But I have to say – I am really curious about all this”.

Katsuki snorted.

“Don’t worry about it”, he said, even though *he* was worried.

He hung up and put the phone down on the bed, beside him. He went back to staring at his ceiling.

He could feel himself starting to get sleepier, and the silence in the dorms – which was something unusual and therefore meant to be enjoyed – was only helping his brain to relax. Before he knew better, his eyes had slipped closed and his mind was wandering idly, thinking about how his day had been and how he planned for the morrow to be.

Until someone knocked on his door.

Annoyance immediately sparked through him, but he was able to keep the feeling at bay. Maybe it was an effect of all those shitty meds he was taking, along with the sleepiness. Either way, he turned slowly on the bed and sat up carefully, trying his best not to move too abruptly lest he aggravate his healing injury.

“I didn’t think you’d get here so fast, Shitty H–“, he started to say as he limped to the door, only to open it and reveal a stoic Todoroki.

He was cut off by his own surprise, staring at the Half’n’Half bastard with shocked eyes that soon enough became narrowed and suspicious.

“*You*”, he said accusingly.

Todoroki wasn’t affected by his clearly sour mood.

“Bakugou”, he said simply. And then, straight to the point: “I wanted to speak to you”.

Katsuki huffed through his nose.

“Yeah, I bet you did. It’s about Deku, isn’t it?”

Todoroki nodded solemnly, not even surprised by the fact that Katsuki had guessed it right so easily. Katsuki crossed his arms above his chest.

“Shouldn’t you be in class?”, he provoked.

Todoroki simply stared at him with a neutral face.

“I should. But I figured that our conversation might turn into a shouting match, in which case I’d rather have it happen while our friends are not within the hearing range. I don’t want to call their attention. So I skipped class to come talk to you”.

Katsuki huffed again, unimpressed.

“Well, if it’s about Deku, I’m sure there’ll be some shouting involved”.

Todoroki raised an eyebrow at him.

Katsuki stepped out of his room and closed the door behind him. Icy Hot was right – there was no one around to hear them, which meant it wouldn’t be necessary for them to have this talk inside his room. He didn’t want the bastard to go in again – once had been enough already.

“So you know about me and him”, Katsuki started, taking charge of the conversation.

“Yes”, a straight answer.

“And you want to fight over him?”

That finally sent some emotion to Todoroki’s stoic face. The emotion was raw confusion.

“I’m… sorry, what?”, he asked, frowning.

Katsuki scoffed.

“Don’t try to play me. I know you want him”, he accused. “And you can’t have him”.

Todoroki continued to frown and blink at Katsuki, as if he hadn’t predicted the course this conversation was taking.

“What are you talking about?”, he questioned.

Katsuki took a furious step closer to him, and hated the way his torso twisted in pain and discomfort. He tried to hide the pain behind a growl.

“Listen here, fuckface”, he said through a snarl. “I’m not gonna say that Deku is mine because he’s not a thing that someone can own. But he’s with me. So that’s as close to being mine as he can get. Which means that you and Round Face are gonna back the fuck off and keep those grabby hands of yours away from my fucking man, do you hear me?”

Todoroki continued to stare at him with the upmost confusion.

“I…”, he stuttered, which was an uncommon sight for him. “You think I want to *date* Midoriya?”, he asked, with an emotion that was close to mortification.

Katsuki’s snarl grew in size.

“In your *dreams*”, he said, aggressive. “Like I said, he’s with *me*”.

Todoroki opened and closed his mouth before sighing heavily, scratching the back of his neck in surprise and confusion. He stared at the floor for a few moments before he met Katsuki’s eyes again.

“You know, this is not what I had in mind when I came here to talk to you”, he admitted. “I know Midoriya told us about the two of you, which was why I came over in the first place. I wanted to make sure you wouldn’t hurt him”.

Katsuki felt his chest twist at that. He wanted to be mad at Todoroki for making such an assumption, but who was he kidding? He had worried about that possibility himself. It was natural for Icy Hot to think he’d hurt Deku if they got to close, because Katsuki had never done anything but.

But he could change. And he would show them. Every single one of them.

“I know I was a piece of shit to him in the past”, he admitted, overtaken by a sudden sense of honesty. “And I hurt him in more ways than you’d know. If you think you know shit about the two of us and how we grew up, you’re mistaken”, he added, feeling clingy to that warm sense of intimacy in his relationship with Deku. “But I won’t do it again. If he chose to be with me, then I’ll make sure I’m the best option available for him. I’ll stomp down any competition I find in my way, and that includes you if it comes to it”, he added.

Todoroki nodded.

“You don’t have to worry about me as competition”, he said easily, and Katsuki felt honesty in his voice. “I like Midoriya, but only as a friend”.

Katsuki huffed.

“Yeah, right”.

“I mean it”.

“Look, you don’t have to lie to me. Just stop giving Deku those thirsty looks you give him and keep your icy-hot hands away from him and we’ll be cool”.

Todoroki would have blushed if he was any other person.

“I don’t know what you’re talking about”, he said stoically. “But as I said, Midoriya is a good friend and I value his friendship. That’s why I wanted to talk to you. But you seem very… passionate about him. And I know that you no longer do things the way you used to do, with everything that happened”.

Katsuki narrowed his eyes. He didn’t really like the idea that people were perceiving him as someone who had changed, but he didn’t really know how to counter that, either. Because what could he say? The person he had been a year before wasn’t the same person he was today. Now, he had more patience, more scars, and he spent his free time thinking of ways he could give Deku the perfect first date. If his persona from one year before had witnessed him today, he didn’t know what he would have fucking said, but he was pretty sure a series of curses would be involved.

“Like I said, I won’t hurt him”, he repeated for good measure. “So if that’s all, you can fuck off back to class and I can go take my meds”.

Todoroki continued to stare at him.

“Not hurting him is not enough”, he pointed out. “It’s a basic requirement. What I do want to know is if you’ll make him happy”.

That made Katsuki’s blood boil a little more.

“What is it to *you*?”, he questioned, leaning his head closer to Todoroki, who took a deep breath.

“I’m his friend”, he repeated. “And I’m worried about his happiness. We all are”.

Katsuki’s nostrils flared.

“You all underestimate me so much”, he accused. “You, Round Face, Four Eyes and Frog Girl can all go *fuck* yourselves if you think I won’t do anything and everything in my power to be the best damn boyfriend this world has ever seen”.

Todoroki raised his eyebrows, unimpressed.

“So is that what you are?”, he questioned. “Boyfriends?”

Katsuki huffed, but didn’t say anything. *We’re not boyfriends just yet. Not until we have a proper date.*

Todoroki nodded when he remained silent, as if he had been expecting that.

“He told us about the kiss, but everything else seemed… uncertain”, he commented. “Which was another reason for me to come here”.

“Since when did you become the spokesperson to Deku’s feelings?”, Katsuki inquired. “If he’s got a problem with our relationship, he can come to me himself”.

“He doesn’t know I’m here”, Todoroki pointed out. “He didn’t ask me to speak for him. I’m only doing this because I care about his wellbeing, and I care about yours too, even if you deny to see it”.

Katsuki squinted.

“All I’m saying is that I’m not one hundred percent sure that you and Midoriya are better when you’re with each other. That’s not a criticism on your personality or his, is just the way I see you. You seem to bring each other to the edge, which is not something good in a long-term relationship. I speak from experience. The last thing I’d want for either of you is to see you fall apart because you burned too bright at the beginning. But if you can assure that you won’t hurt his feelings, I’ll be on my way”.

“What about him hurting my feelings, huh?”, Katsuki provoked. “Since you said you care about the two of us?”

Todoroki sighed.

“That was implied”.

“No, it wasn’t”, Katsuki scorned. “And that’s fine. I don’t need anyone out there worrying about me, especially not you”.

Todoroki sighed again.

“Bakugou”, he said calmly, stoically. “I do worry about you. In fact, I’d find your loss hard to overcome”.

Katsuki blinked at Todoroki, confused.

“You don’t have to be my friend if you don’t want to”, he continued. “And whatever rivalry you might think we have over Midoriya, I can assure you it’s not true. Like I said, he’s a friend. A dear one, but only that. So maybe we could be friends too, if you’re willing to. I feel like I failed you back at the Training Camp, and I want to make up for that if I can, in the future. If you let me”.

Katsuki studied his face. He seemed serious, and that little emotional speech had more sentiment than anything Katsuki had heard come out of his mouth in years. Still, he felt the need to poke at Todoroki’s wound, just to see how far he’d go.

“Me, friends with you?”, he scoffed. “As *if*”.

Todoroki seemed disappointed, but not surprised.

“Well, that’s your choice”, he said simply. “As long as you don’t make Midoriya unhappy, I’ll have no beef with you”.

He turned on his heels and started to walk down the corridor. Katsuki watched him go, trying to decide how he felt about being dismissed like that so easily, so stoically.

“Oi, Icy Hot”, he called after Todoroki just as he was about to turn the corner. The boy stopped walking and turned to look at Katsuki.

There was a moment of hesitance.

And then:

“Thanks”, he said honestly. Even if he was jealous, he was glad to know that Deku had worried friends watching his back.

“For what?”, Todoroki asked, sincere.

Katsuki sighed.

“For worrying about Deku. And the shit you said about my loss. You don’t have to make shit up to me for the Training Camp, so get that out of your double-colored head”.

Todoroki stared at him blankly.

“I’ll see you around”, he said simply. And then he disappeared at the end of the corridor.

Katsuki was in the middle of a very pleasant nap when someone knocked on his door. With an irritated growl, he removed his face from the crook of his arm and rubbed the sleepiness away from his eyes.

“Uuuuughhhhh”, he sighed gutturally. “I’m comin’”, he shouted at whoever it was at his door. He slowly sat up on the bed and hissed at the way his injury protested. He took a hand to it and pressed down, blinking his eyes several times as they adjusted to the dim lighting of the room.

Great. He had slept the afternoon away.

He got up and turned the lights on before limping to the door, opening it to reveal Kirishima and… his mom? Right behind him?

“Hey, look who I found downstairs!”, Kirishima cheered, as if he had arrived to a fucking party or something. He pointed his thumb at Mitsuki to show her to Katsuki. She had a grumpy face on.

“Great, my two worst nightmares combined”, he said as a teasing, stepping aside so they could enter the room.

“Don’t be like that, bro!”, Kirishima strolled in easily, since he was familiar with the room, and he tapped Katsuki on the shoulder before approaching his bed and sitting down on the edge of it.

His mom, on the other hand, had never been to Katsuki’s UA dorm room, so she strolled in slowly, looking around and taking the room in. Katsuki closed the door behind her to prevent his nosy friends from trying to take a peek of his room or his conversation.

“Hey, brat”, she said simply, offering him a little plastic bag. “Here’s your valentine necklace”.

“Valentine necklace?!”, Kirishima exclaimed, eyes popping wide. He stared at Katsuki as the boy opened the plastic bag to reveal the limited-edition soulmate necklace he had required, as well as some bright-colored wrapping paper.

“I didn’t ask for wrapping paper”, he pointed out, to which his mom promptly replied:

“You didn’t have to. I wouldn’t let you give the boy a gift without wrapping it in some fancy papers. For fuck’s sake, Katsuki, have some class”, she reprimanded.

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“Can I see it?”, Kirishima asked, propping himself on his seat. He seemed extremely curious, so Katsuki tossed the bag at him as if it was garbage. Kirishima grabbed it in the air and immediately shoved his face inside it, eager to see what it was about.

“I’ll give you the money, then you can go”, Katsuki told his mom, limping over to his study desk and grabbing his wallet. “I don’t even know how they let you inside the boy’s dorm in the first place”.

“I have my ways”, she said mysteriously, but Kirishima said at the same time:

“She can yell louder than you. I don’t know how you didn’t hear it from here”.

Katsuki huffed.

“I was sleeping”.

“What, at this time?!”, Mitsuki exclaimed, sounding shocked and offended by that very idea. Whatever thin patience Katsuki had left in his body wasn’t enough for him to keep his cool.

“I’m still recovering, you old hag!”, he exploded, angry. “Recovery Girl said I need to rest if I want to get better, so I’m just following medical orders! I’m not slacking around!”, he

added for good measure.

“No one said you were slacking around!”, Mitsuki shouted back, defensive. “Why do you always put words in my damn mouth in order to play the victim?”

“I’m no one’s victim!”, Katsuki shouted, the yen bills starting to fume in his hand.

“You tell that to the villain who dropped a building on you!”

“Fuck off!”

“You fuck off!”

“Guys!”, Kirishima said, getting up from the bed and placing himself between the two of them before they could go for each other’s throat. “You need to stop this! Here”, he took the money from Katsuki’s fisted hand with only a bit of difficulty, pulling it free from his grip before turning to Mitsuki. “See, there you go”, he said calmly, placing the money in her hand. “There’s your money. Everything’s settled now, right?”

Mitsuki straightened her clothes and huffed with indignance, but she did grab her purse and shoved her money inside in silence. Then, to Katsuki’s and Kirishima’s surprise, she didn’t turn to leave – and instead she sat at the edge of Katsuki’s bed, crossing her legs and resting her hands atop her knee. When Katsuki stared at her with evident confusion on his face, she shrugged.

“Kirishima told me you two were going to plan your date with Midoriya”, she said, as if that explained anything.

“So?”, Katsuki shrugged back at her.

“So I’m going to take part at this!”, she said a bit too aggressively to someone who was offering help. “It’s my son’s first date, and we both know that you suck at this kind of thing. I’ll stay and help”.

That sent another snarl to Katsuki’s face.

“You have no way of knowing whether I suck at this or not”, he pointed out. “I’ve never dated anyone!”

Mitsuki nodded promptly.

“Exactly. That’s why you need help”.

Katsuki scoffed.

“What, you think that you’re gonna shout at me and suddenly I’ll become all romantic?”, he asked. “Wake the fuck up. If Deku’s gonna take me, he’s gonna take me for what I am. With or without pretty flowers and tuxedos and whatever the hell else you expect me to pull off”.

Kirishima sat down beside Mitsuki slowly, apprehension in his face.

“Uh, I don’t know, man”, he said. “Maybe your mom has some good tips for you, since she knows you best and all that. Hearing her out wouldn’t hurt”.

“He was being nice to you. It wouldn’t hurt to be nice back”.

“Yes, it would”.

“No, Kacchan, it wouldn’t! Why don’t you just try it?”

Katsuki sighed. Stupid Deku with his stupid advice.

“Fine. But if any of you mock me or try to give me shit for what I’m about to say, I’ll kick you out, understand?”, he threatened.

“Just spit out your plan and let’s find a way to make it better”, Mitsuki crossed her arms above her chest. Kirishima gave him two thumbs up and a broad smile, to which Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“Fine”, he gave in. He pulled his rolling chair from his study desk and placed it directly in front of his best friend and his mom, sitting down on it. The relief of taking his weight from his throbbing injury was almost immediate. “My plan was to take shitty Deku to the same place where these assholes threw me a surprise birthday party earlier this year. But Aizawa sensei told me I can’t leave the school grounds until I’m one hundred percent better, so that’s a no-go”.

Mitsuki nodded.

“I knew I was right to trust this school”, she said. “They’re very responsible”.

Katsuki gave her a look.

“Yeah, apart from the time I got literally kidnapped by the League of Villains and the whole other month they spent lying to me and Deku about his body’s real state, which resulted in me taking the matter into my own hands and losing my hearing in the process”, he said, purposefully leaving the part where he hurt Deku’s soul out of the information. That still bothered him a lot and hit a bit too close to home for him to use it as leverage just yet.

“Yeah, apart from that”, Mitsuki nodded simply.

Katsuki hated when she acted like that, but he decided to be the better man and just focus on his patient side. The one that was taking meds, deep breaths, and calming stances. *Good thoughts, good words, good deeds*.

“*Anyway*”, he said emphatically. “Since I can’t leave the school, I’ll have to have the date here. Deku’s already talked to his friends about this shit and everyone knows already, but I won’t be able to call myself his boyfriend until we do the proper ritual. So I want to do that already, I can’t wait until I’m better enough to go out. I was thinking about it, and I think I decided a place. But I’m going to need help to bring a couple of chairs and a table out, as well as the food I’m going to cook. Which is where you come in”, he pointed at Kirishima. “I would carry all that shit there myself, but I can’t just yet because of my healing injury. I don’t

want to make it worse by carrying weight and end up with even more off-days and hospital stays", he justified, feeling just a little bit ashamed for being forced to ask for help.

"Of course I'll help, bro!", Kirishima exclaimed happily, sounding excited.

"I don't know if we're going to find a small dinner table here at UA, so we might have to buy one. And since I can't leave – you'll have to buy it", he pointed at Kirishima again.

"Why didn't you tell me sooner? I was at the mall, I could have bought you one", Mitsuki protested. Katsuki rolled his eyes in response.

"I didn't tell you because I didn't know your nosy ass would stay here to help with the plan", he pointed out.

"Show your mother some respect, brat", Mitsuki reprimanded, but it was half-hearted. "What's this special place you're taking Midoriya to anyway?"

Katsuki bit his inner cheeks and lowered his head.

"Ground Beta", he muttered.

Kirishima's eyebrows arched up high to demonstrate his surprise, whereas Mitsuki continued to stare at her son with a blank face. Upon both of their silences, she turned her head to give Kirishima a confused look, which she then directed to Katsuki.

"Am I supposed to know where that is?", she inquired.

"Ground Beta is the place where they both fought each other a loooong time ago", Kirishima explained. "It's also where their relationship started to get better".

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

"It didn't start to get better *then*", he said, thinking back to all of those ghost-Deku days and the long path they had trailed on ever since.

"It kind of did. You guys were nicer to each other during house arrest".

"Shut the hell up, Shitty Hair", Katsuki huffed.

"Oh, so it's a symbolic place!", Mitsuki said, excited. "It used to be a place where you fought, and now it will be a place where you make out!"

"I'm not making out with him there!", Katsuki protested, angry and embarrassed. He was very new to all this dating stuff, he didn't know how to react to other people's teasing, especially not to his mom's.

"Oh, you don't have to be so embarrassed!", Mitsuki provoked. "If I know anything about Midoriya, he'll appreciate the gesture. Honestly, I think he'll appreciate anything you do for him. You two were so close to each other when you were little…"

Katsuki rolled his eyes again.

“Enough with the sentimental talk”, he cut her off. “Let’s talk facts. I need a small dinner table. It can be plastic, plastic is cheaper. I’ll cover it with a nice tablecloth so he can’t see it’s plastic. Ok, maybe I’ll buy a wooden one. Then all I’ll need is some candles, and I’ll handle the food. So we’ll eat and I’ll propose to him”.

Mitsuki burst into laughter.

Kirishima looked embarrassed whereas Katsuki looked furious, but neither of the boys said anything as she continued to laugh, slapping one hand at her knee and bending over with her arms wrapped about her belly. The laughing fit continued for a few more moments before she wiped her teary eyes and went back to sitting in a normal position. Katsuki narrowed his eyes at her.

“Are you done?”, he asked dryly.

Mitsuki nodded, sniffing, and a smile continued to tinge her lips as she came down from her fit.

“Sorry”, she said, which was a good start. “I’m not mocking you or anything, but – *proposing?*”, she said, as if the phrasing was ridiculous. “You’re getting married to him at the tender age of 17?”

Katsuki gave her an angry look.

“I meant I’m going to ask him to be my *boyfriend*”, he clarified.

Mitsuki looked like she was holding back another laughing fit, but this time she managed to control it better. Maybe it had to do with the serious, upset look on Katsuki’s face.

“Ok, so you need a small table, a tablecloth and some candles, right?”, she asked him.

Katsuki nodded silently, still a bit angry at her.

“And what are you going to cook him again?”, she continued.

“Katsudon”, Katsuki said. “It’s his favorite dish”.

Mitsuki smiled at him, and now the gesture was less mocking and more warm. She stood up from his bed and took a step closer to her son, placing a hand on his shoulder. This seemed to be her own special way of silently apologizing for having laughed at him.

“I shouldn’t have underestimated you”, she admitted. “You seem to have your shit together. That’s a good plan”.

Katsuki’s grumpy expression softened a little at this, and he didn’t resist when his mom pulled him into a hug. He didn’t hug her back, but he didn’t push her away either.

His mom finally let go of him, leaning back but keeping her hands on his shoulders. She gave him a look that was almost affectionate, cupping his face into her hand.

“Midoriya is lucky to have you”, she said tenderly. It seemed like she had realized that her humorous reaction had offended Katsuki. “Sorry for yelling at you”.

Katsuki huffed, not used to hearing his old woman say things like “sorry”.

“Have *you* been going to therapy?”, he jested, thinking back to her comment from their call from earlier.

She rolled her eyes.

“No”, she said. “But I nearly lost you. It makes me think back to all those times I could have been nicer to you, but wasn’t”.

Katsuki made a face at her.

“Being cheesy doesn’t suit you”, he accused.

“It doesn’t suit you either”, his mother was quick to shoot back. “And yet, here you are, planning your date with your future boyfriend”.

He sighed and stood up from his rolling chair. His mother placed a supportive hand beneath his elbow, and then she grabbed his arm to capture his attention. He looked at her.

“I think he’s good to you”, she said. “So be good to him, too”.

That reminded him of Todoroki’s words from earlier. For some reason, it angered him. The emotion must have shown on his face, because before he could say anything, his mom continued:

“I’m not saying you’re not going to be good to him”, she pointed out. “I’m just saying that – I’m like you”, she shrugged. “I’m angry and impulsive and explosive. Your teacher says it has to do with our quirk, and you inherited it from me. This is how we’ve always been”, she said. “But you don’t have to be a foul-mouthed brat all the time. The fact that you came up with all this just to make Midoriya happy is proof of that. Proof that you can be better than me”.

Katsuki gave her a crooked smile and an eye roll.

“I mean it”, she insisted. “When I was going out with your dad, I wasn’t the romantic one. In fact, I was so aggressive that I didn’t even leave any room for *him* to try and be romantic. So – I just wanted to say – I’m proud of you. I really am”, she smiled, squeezing his arm.

He wanted to reply with something along the lines of *didn’t I tell you to stop being cheesy?*, but the teasing felt wrong in his tongue. His mom was getting better at her treatment towards him – ever since he woke up at the hospital after the museum incident, she had been gentler and kinder to him. She still screamed and got into arguments with him sometimes – the shouting match they had had just a few minutes before was enough proof of that. But Katsuki

didn’t mind that. He had never minded that, even though some of his mother’s harsh words stuck with him like a ghost at the back of his mind – especially the ones about him being weak.

He liked this new version of his mother. The one that caressed him and supported him, rather than just complaining about him all the time. He could handle a little screaming and a little bit of harsh truths every now and then – after all, he was tough. But seeing her demonstrate her care for him through gestures and words also felt good in a way he couldn’t really describe. Maybe he had been spoiled by Inko, who was always so delicate towards him, so considerate, even when she wanted to be harsh.

Inko.

Fuck, he’d almost forgotten about her. He shrugged away from his mom’s hold of his arm and limped to his study desk, where his phone was resting. He grabbed it and looked at the screen. There were no new texts or missed calls, thankfully, which indicated that she hadn’t arrived at the school.

From: Katsuki Bakugou

Where are you?

“When’s your date with him anyway? You’re going to tell me or what?”, Mitsuki asked behind him. Katsuki turned to face her.

“Tomorrow”, he said. His mother’s eyebrows shot up.

“So you need that table for *tomorrow*?”, she asked, and her tone didn’t sound exactly optimistic. “You should have told me this when you called me, brat”.

“Leave it to Kirishima”, Katsuki said. “He can take Mina to the store and buy it with her”.

“Uh, I –“, Kirishima tried to say, but Mitsuki was fast to cut him off.

“I’ll buy you the damn table. Just make sure to have this date at night, so I have enough time to buy it and bring it here to you”, Mitsuki growled at the same time Katsuki’s phone vibrated in his hand.

From: Deku's Mom

I'm on my way. Katsuki-kun. I will arrive soon…

"Oi. Don't ignore me when I talk to you", Mitsuki tapped his shoulder with force, meaning to call his attention. Katsuki sighed and stared up at her. "Who are you even talking to?"

"None of your business", Katsuki said, blocking the phone and putting it away. "If you insist you're going to get the damn table instead of Kirishima, then get to it. I have other shit to do".

Kirishima grimaced, whereas Mitsuki simply raised one eyebrow at her son.

"Keep talking to me like that and I'll make sure I personally ruin your date", she threatened.

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

"I'm just handling some shit I need to solve before the date", he explained vaguely.

"What shit? Do you need anything else?", Mitsuki asked, genuinely interested.

"No", Katsuki shook his head.

He sat down on the edge of the bed beside Kirishima, trying to pretend he had done it out of his own free will rather than for the pain that was starting to burn on his torso. He had ended up sleeping through his alarm that indicated when he should take his meds, which was probably why his injury was acting up like that. He wouldn't be able to keep this conversation up for much longer like this.

"Oi, Shitty Hair", Katsuki called, making his friend turn to stare at him. "See my mom out of the building for me. I don't want to have to go downstairs right now, I'm busy with other shit", he made up.

Mitsuki squinted at him.

"Fine. No need to kick me out", she said adjusting her purse on her shoulder and getting close to her son. "I'll bring your ungrateful ass your damn table for the date. Take your meds and behave, Katsuki", she instructed, ruffling his hair. "Come on, Kirishima", she called the boy, who obediently got up and followed her to the door.

"Be right back, bro", Kirishima told him above his shoulder.

"No need to come back here", Katsuki said simply. "But keep an eye on your phone".

Kirishima frowned.

“What? Why?”

“Because I’ll text you, dipshit”, Katsuki sighed.

Mitsuki opened the door of the bedroom and turned on her heels to stare at Katsuki through narrowed eyes.

“Why text him? What do you have to say to him that you can’t say in front of me?”, she questioned.

Katsuki groaned loudly and let himself fall back on his bed, his legs dangling off the edge.

“Not everything is about you, old hag”, he sighed.

“Ok, sorry for being a worried mom who doesn’t want her son to plan a shitty date”, Mitsuki complained. “You know what, I wash my hands. I’ll get you your stupid table and that’s all you’re getting from me”.

“Good. Now, bye”, Katsuki said simply, not looking at her or at Kirishima.

The moment he heard the door close, Katsuki lifted his head from the mattress and stared at it to make sure they were gone. Then, he sat up on the bed again – slowly, minding his injury – and grabbed his meds from the study desk. He had kept from taking them in front of his mom and Kirishima because he hadn’t wanted them to question him about skipping his meds, and because he didn’t really like the idea of reinforcing their image of him as a recovering invalid. He didn’t need anyone’s sympathy or pity, even if he was pretty much in pain.

The meds would take a while to kick in. Katsuki usually took them in the middle of the afternoon because that was a time in which he wasn’t in so much pain yet. But since he had slept through his alarm, the pain had enough time to grow and grow until he could barely remain on his feet. And the medicine, in its slow course, would take a while to have an effect on his body.

Gritting his teeth without realizing, he checked his phone again. No new messages from Inko, but according to her last text, she would be there soon. Katsuki couldn’t really meet her on the boy’s dorm, since that would be a likely place for Deku to show up and walk into their conversation, which was why he found himself typing:

From: Katsuki Bakugou

Meet me at Recovery Girl’s medbay

He didn't wait for a reply before he opened his chat with Kirishima.

From: Best Friend

I need a favor from you

From: Best Friend

Other than plotting the table thing with my mom

The reply was almost immediate.

From: Shitty Hair

I am keeping an eye on my phone as I was thoroughly instructed

From: Best Friend

Good

From: Best Friend

I need you to distract Deku for me

From: Best Friend

Make sure he doesn't go anywhere near Recovery Girl's medbay

From: Shitty Hair

What? Why?

From: Shitty Hair

Is everything all right?

From: Shitty Hair

Are you going to the medbay?

From: Best Friend

Yes but before your stupid ass gets worried, I'm ok

From: Best Friend

I'm meeting his mom there, which is why I don't want him to show up

From: Best Friend

So keep him from going there ok? By any means necessary

From: Shitty Hair

You've got it bro

From: Shitty Hair

But why are you meeting his mom there? Why is his mom even at UA at this time?

From: Shitty Hair

Oh

From: Shitty Hair

Ooooooooh

From: Shitty Hair

You're going to ask her for her blessing?????????

From: Shitty Hair

That's it, isn't it????????

From: Shitty Hair

I may be kind of dumb but I totally nail Bakugou-stuff

From: Shitty Hair

I'm right, aren't I? You're asking for her blessing??

From: Shitty Hair

Bakugou are you there

From: Shitty Hair

I can see you're seeing my messages you're just opting not to reply to them

From: Shitty Hair

Bakugouuuuu

From: Shitty Hair

Bakugouuuuuuuuuuuuuuuu

From: Best Friend

Just shut the fuck up and keep Deku in the dorm building.

Katsuki set down his phone and stared at the cane that were propped on his desk. The thought of walking up to Inko using shitty canes was disturbing, but he knew he had to do it. He could almost picture it in his mind: if he didn't have a first date with Deku, he wouldn't be able to call themselves boyfriends. If he didn't call Deku his boyfriend, the nerd would get all upset and teary-eyed and he would certainly think that Katsuki didn't really like him or that he was ashamed of him. Deku wouldn't bring this up and would suffer on his own. Then they would have a stupid argument over stupid shit and Deku would throw it on his face or question him about it.

No, delaying their first date was the route to disaster. And Katsuki's rush to settle this matter had nothing to do with his own desire to be able to officialize his thing with Deku. Nope. Not at all.

From: Shitty Hair

Fine, I'll keep him away from there. But I want a full report on that talk you're having with Mrs. Midoriya later, ok?

From: Shitty Hair

I've never been more curious in my life man I'm not joking

With a sigh, Katsuki grabbed his cane. He was still in pain, but he was counting on the medicine to have an effect before Inko arrived. In the clothes he was wearing, he marched out of his room, taking the elevator to prevent from any of their friends meeting him in the stairs.

Actually, as much as he hated to admit it, he wouldn't be able to go down all the way through the stairs, not in the state he was in.

Recovery was a bitch, but he wished it would be a *faster* bitch.

He was sitting at the waiting area when Inko arrived, breathless.

"Katsuki-kun", she exclaimed as soon as she saw him. "What's the matter?"

Katsuki left his cane aside and pushed himself to his feet with a barely audible groan, limping towards Inko. She looked pale and frantic, as if she was expecting some terrible news, and Katsuki felt a little bad for putting the woman through so much distress. Maybe he should have gone straight to the point through the phone.

But he knew he couldn't have done that. The talk he wanted to have needed to happen face to face.

"Everything's ok", he said, subconsciously taking one hand to his injury and pressing down on it. "You don't need to worry so much".

Inko followed his hand down to his torso, and then her eyes focused on the cane behind him, which was propped against one of the waiting chairs. She took a trembling hand to her mouth, and Katsuki realized that this was the first time Inko was seeing him after the museum incident.

"Oh, dear…", she whispered, sounding heartbroken. "You're… You're sure you shouldn't be in bed?"

That offended him.

"I'm fine", he said angrily, emphatically. Inko continued to eye him with big worried green eyes, but Katsuki simply sighed at the sight. "I really am", he added for good measure. "I'm recovering well, and I won't need that shit anymore soon", he nodded at the cane.

Inko took her purse away from her shoulder and placed it on one of the chairs, taking a step closer to him.

“Why did you need me to come over?”, she asked, sounding anguished. “I knew it must be something serious, if you couldn’t talk about it over the phone, and I’ve been dying of curiosity… I’m sorry for being so straightforward”, she bowed, but Katsuki simply shook his head.

“You don’t need to be so worried”, Katsuki said simply. “Let’s sit down”, he added, pretending the courtesy was more for her sake than his own. She seemed distraught enough to need to sit down.

Inko nodded obediently and took a seat beside her purse. Katsuki took the seat next to her, doing his best not to groan as he lowered himself down.

“When you asked me to meet you at the medical bay, I feared the worst”, she admitted, hand trembling on her lap. “Can you… Can you please tell me what’s going on?”

Katsuki sighed, trying to organize his thoughts.

“I asked you to meet me here because I didn’t want to risk Deku overhearing us”, he said, trying to ease her. The statement sent a frown to Inko’s brow.

“Why can’t he overhear us?”, she asked, blinking her big green eyes at Katsuki. The sight still disturbed him, even after all that time.

“Because the conversation I want to have with you is private. I… I’ll tell him about it, later. But first, I need us to talk in private. This is the quietest place in this hellhole of a school”, he said.

Inko nodded attentively, though she still looked worried, waiting for him to continue.

Katsuki averted his eyes downwards, biting at his lower lip. He didn’t want to admit to himself that he was nervous, but there was no better word to describe his sentiment at that moment. He felt ridiculous and pathetic. Inko was such a tiny woman, with a meaningless quirk. He shouldn’t be afraid of her. He shouldn’t be afraid of anyone.

But this? This was about Deku. Which meant that all of Katsuki’s laws and rules, which applied to everything else, didn’t apply to Deku. His mom was included in that equation.

“Has he talked to you?”, Katsuki started, not looking at her. The tension in the waiting room was nearly tangible.

“T-Talked to me?”, Inko questioned.

“About what happened when he went after me”, Katsuki said. “In the debris, and then here at the medbay”.

Silence. He lifted his eyes to look at her, but now she was the one avoiding his gaze. Her cheeks were pink.

“D-Do you m-mean… Has he talked to me about… the… the… Kiss?”, she stuttered hesitantly.

Katsuki swallowed dry. *Chin up, be brave.*

"Yes", he said, serious. Inko looked at him, and then she looked away again. She nodded silently, her hands gripping the hem of her skirt and twisting the material in her nervousness.

"Yes, he d-did", she said firmly, as if she was gathering up her strength to do so. "And I told him that I support him no matter what – whether he likes boys or girls or whoever he has feelings for, I'll support him, as long as he is happy. That's – That's all I want. For my son to be happy".

Katsuki nodded, serious.

"That's what I want to talk to you about", he said. "Deku's happiness".

That seemed to take her by surprise. She raised her head to stare at him, frowning.

"What do you mean?", she inquired.

Katsuki took a deep breath.

"I know I did shit in the past", he said, feeling raw and exposed. "I know I hurt him. On purpose. And I know you already said you forgave me for all that shit", he pointed out. "But forgiving me for that shit I did doesn't mean you endorse… *this*", he gestured at himself, hoping she would understand. "And I don't think you should make decisions for Deku, just as much as I won't let my parents make decisions for me. We're both months away from becoming legal adults. But still, I know how important you are to Deku, and how much he loves you. I know it would break his heart if he had to choose between me and you. And I don't want to put him in that position. I don't want to force him to make a choice. So what I'm trying to say is –"

"You're asking for my blessing", Inko filled in the blank.

Katsuki stared at her. He swallowed dry, then he nodded.

Inko nodded back. She offered him a quick smile, but her lower lip was trembling and she looked like she wanted to cry.

"You know, when Izuku told me about the kiss, I was so confused", she admitted. "Not about his sexuality or anything like that, but because… I mean, I should have seen this coming", she smiled again, shrugging.

For some reason, that annoyed Katsuki. His relationship with Deku wasn't obvious; no one would have been able to see it coming.

"He's always loved you so much", Inko continued before Katsuki could voice his complaint. Her words made him keep from interrupting, however. "He's always – admired you, and talked about you, and *praised* you so much. I should have known it would be you, when the time came. In my heart, he's still my little boy, but deep down I knew this day would arrive. You know, the day he would want to date people and have a relationship and even marry someday. Every mother has to prepare herself for that, right? But my Izuku has always been

so alone, you know… I feared that, when the day came, he would be lost. He wouldn't have a clue of what to do, the poor thing. But then… he's always known his way around you", she smiled, meeting his eyes.

Katsuki stared at her in silence. Waiting for a response.

Inko lowered her head, her smile becoming sad.

"I know what you did to him in the past. And like you said yourself, I already forgave you for that", she said. Then, she met his eyes, sustaining his gaze. "And I think that, out of anyone, you're the best person to be with him. Because I know from experience how much you've grown to care about him, and how strong you are to protect him. When a mother gives birth, she dreads the day her son will become a hero, because being a hero means he'll always put other people's lives above his own. But with you by his side, I know there will always be someone watching his back".

Katsuki wanted to say *so you think I'm a fucking bodyguard or something*, but he knew where Inko was coming from. And she was right – they both wanted to be heroes, and they both wanted to achieve number one. Even if Katsuki had always considered himself a lone wolf, he knew that if they worked together, they would be able to become the best of the best, because they would always have someone striving to the top to watch their backs.

"You have my permission, and my blessing", Inko said, reaching out to grab one of Katsuki's hands. She squeezed it and offered him a teary-eyed smile. "As long as you make my Izuku happy, and protect him in the ways I can't, you'll always have my blessing".

Katsuki bit his inner cheeks and nodded.

"I'll ask him to be my boyfriend tomorrow", he said, stern. He always got a bit awkward by Inko's demonstrations of affection, which were always so open, so raw. "I wanted to talk to you about it, first, before I actually talked to *him* about it".

Inko squeezed his hand again one more time before she let go, settling back.

"I'm curious", she admitted. "What would you have done if I said no?"

Katsuki thought about it. The possibility had occurred to him, and as it was his usual, he didn't particularly enjoy to be bossed around by anyone. If Deku's mom had been against their relationship, there was nothing he could do about it. But would he let it stop him from being with Deku? Would he put Deku in a position where he'd have to choose between his mother and his boyfriend?

He truly didn't know. He knew that choice would make Deku unhappy, and that was the last thing he wanted. But he also knew that not being with him would also make Deku unhappy. It was a catch-22.

"I think I'd try to convince you", Katsuki admitted, feeling surprisingly calm. "Because I know for a fact that I love Deku. And I think I've loved him for a while now, even if it took me a while to understand it. And to act on it".

Inko nodded, giving him a warm, affectionate look.

“You’re a good boy, Katsuki-kun”, she said. “You’ve always been a good boy, even if you strayed for a while. All I ask of you is to make my Izuku happy – if you do that, there is no reason for me to be against your relationship”.

Katsuki nodded. He didn’t know how to handle the wave of relief and fear that were coursing through him. Relief, because he wouldn’t have to put Deku through an impossible dilemma; fear because now there was nothing standing in the way of him and his proposal.

“Sorry for scaring you with my call”, Katsuki said, because that felt like it needed to be said. “I didn’t mean to stress you out; I just didn’t think that this was a subject to be talked over the phone”.

Inko nodded her head.

“I understand where you were coming from. I’ll admit your call scared me, and your text about meeting at the medical bay must have given me new grey hairs. It didn’t even cross my mind that you wanted to talk about the kiss, silly old me”, she smiled, shaking her head. “But I can see you are a very responsible and respectable boy, if you went through all that trouble just to ask for my consent”.

Katsuki nodded.

“I would have asked Deku’s dad too, but I know he hasn’t been around”.

Inko’s face fell. She looked away, uncomfortable, and Katsuki suddenly realized he had approached a sensitive subject without really meaning to.

“He… He cares about Izuku a lot, so I’m sure he would support you two”, she smiled awkwardly, and Katsuki grimaced in his mind. “What matters is – is Izuku’s happiness”, she twisted the hem of her skirt.

Katsuki stared at her.

“Well, thanks for coming here”, he said, pushing himself to his feet. “Sorry again for scaring you”.

“Oh, don’t worry about that, all is fine”, Inko said, standing up as well and grabbing her purse. “I’m glad I got the chance to talk to you and to see how you are doing. When Izuku told me about what happened to you, that horrid injury… How are you doing, by the way?”

“Recovery sucks”, Katsuki admitted. “But I’m taking my meds and going to my appointments. I’ll heal”, he shrugged.

Inko nodded. She looked at the cane again, and then back at Katsuki. The question she didn’t want to phrase lingered in the air, and Katsuki sighed.

“That’s just for support”, he clarified. “Until I’m 100% better. I’ll get rid of it in no time”.

Inko nodded at him with a gentle smile, and then she reached out to tap his arm lightly. She looked like she wanted to cup Katsuki's face into her hand, just like his mother had done earlier, but felt too embarrassed to do so.

"I'm sorry for what happened to you", Inko said. "And I'm glad you're recovering".

The touch to his arm was so light and gentle, so endearing. Katsuki hated how much Inko had spoiled him. He had never felt the need for anyone to touch him and caress him and be gentle to him, but now that he knew what it was like, because Inko had shown him, he kept craving for those type of touches and getting frustrated when he got none.

"Thanks", he said simply, pulling away from the touch before it became too overwhelming. Inko blinked, still smiling, and took a step back.

"I'll be on my way, then", she said.

"I'll walk you out", Katsuki said, grabbing his stupid cane and hating it with a vengeance. He ignored its stupid tap-tap-tap on the floor as they walked to the door and turned to Inko. "Also, I wanted to ask you not to tell Deku anything about tomorrow. It's going to be a surprise".

Inko looked at him with interest and curiosity.

"Oh?", she said. "All right. I won't tell him anything".

"Ok", Katsuki said. They reached the exit door. It was night already, and nearly curfew time. He stopped walking and turned to Inko. "Are you going to take the train?"

"Yes", she said. "But you don't have to worry about it, there's plenty of people who take the train at this hour. I won't be alone", she reassured him.

"Ok", he said reluctantly. She must have sensed the hesitation on his tone – the unspoken question he wanted to ask.

"I'll text you when I get home", she promised.

Katsuki hated that he was filled with relief by that.

"Fine", he said begrudgingly.

"Bye, Katsuki-kun", she said, walking at a different direction than him.

"Bye", he said back, heading back towards the dorm. He should probably grab himself something to eat before he went to bed, but he was feeling very tired – despite the afternoon-long nap he had taken – and his healing injury was still throbbing – despite the meds he had taken.

From: Best Friend

She’s gone. You can let Deku go now

From: Shitty Hair

Oh, we’re hanging out at the common room. You should stop buy when you get back! Satou baked a strawberry cake

From: Best Friend

Hard pass. I’m tired as fuck

From: Best Friend

I’m going straight to my room. See you tomorrow

From: Best Friend

Let me know about the table for my date with Deku when you have it

From: Shitty Hair

Ok :-(

From: Shitty Hair

We’ll miss you

Katsuki ignored his sentimental friend and headed back to his room, using the same strategy from before and taking the elevator to avoid his friends. Once he was back in his room, he opened his chat with Deku.

From: Kacchan

Shitty Hair told me you guys are hanging out at the common room

From: Deku

Yeah! Everyone’s here, Satou baked a strawberry cake and some delicious desserts

From: Deku

I saved you a slice, if you want to come down ^_^

From: Kacchan

No thanks. Not up to it

From: Kacchan

How was your day?

From: Deku

Pretty ok, not much happened. I went to class, I studied with Iida-kun and Uraraka-san, then we watched some TV and now we're hanging out with the guys at the common room

From: Deku

What about you?

From: Kacchan

Not much either. I sorted out some shit, slept a bit.

From: Kacchan

Think I'll be going to sleep now. Night

From: Deku

Oh? It's pretty early, even for you

From: Deku

Is everything all right?

From: Kacchan

Yeah, don't worry about me. Save me a slice of the strawberry cake for tomorrow

Katsuki waited for it, but Deku's reply never arrived. Eventually, he grew tired of waiting and decided the nerd was probably busy talking to his friends, and he didn't want to be the annoying boyfriend who got in the way of his partner's fun times.

He changed into more comfortable clothes for him to sleep and put the bag with the necklace away inside his wardrobe. Then, he carefully lied down on the bed, allowing his body to relax, even if it was hard because of the pain in his torso.

It had been worse before his talk to Inko, but now it seemed the medication was finally making an effect. Katsuki closed his eyes and sighed against his pillows, ready to allow unconsciousness to take him over and send him into oblivion. He removed his hearing aids and placed them on the study desk, unlike he had done before his afternoon nap. He was so caught up by the relief that lying down brought him that he didn't even notice – or hear – someone else was there, in the room with him, until he felt the bed shift beside him.

"Shh", Deku soothed him when he jolted into an alert stance. "It's just me", he said, settling down on the bed.

"Idiot", Katsuki muttered, melting back against his pillows with a renovated pain in his torso. "I could have blown you up".

Deku smiled at this, placing himself against Katsuki's back and dropping a kiss on the back of his neck.

"I got worried about you", he said, very close to Katsuki's less-bad ear so that he could hear him without the aids. "So I decided to come over".

Katsuki was still pretty tired, so he simply nestled himself into a fetal position and allowed Deku to cuddle him from the behind. Deku's hand found his spiky hair and he started to caress it with his fingers, which Katsuki found very pleasant and relaxing.

"No need to worry about me", Katsuki said out of habit. "I'm fine".

"You're always saying you're fine", Deku pointed out, dropping another gentle kiss on the back of Katsuki's neck. The gesture sent goosebumps to his skin.

"That's because I'm always fine", he pointed out.

Deku sighed, but he didn't say anything. He continued to caress Katsuki's hair, and soon enough he started to feel sleepy again, sleepy and tired…

"Love you, Kacchan", Izuku said, slipping one hand to Katsuki's chest so that he could feel his heart beating. He spoke too low, though, and thus Katsuki didn't hear him.

"Love you, Deku", Katsuki muttered anyway, out of his own volition, before sleep claimed him.

For a change, no nightmares ridded his brain that night. His sleep was heavy and deep, and the only reason he woke up was because his morning alarm started to beep, indicating it was time for him to take his meds.

“Hnngh”, Deku groaned from beside him, his face buried in his pillows. Katsuki turned the alarm off and Deku nestled himself on the bed, still half-asleep.

He sat up slowly on the bed so that he could reach for his pills on his study desk. He swallowed them dry and immediately lied back down, turning on his side to look at Deku. He was back to sleeping already, his eyes closed and his face slack in a peaceful expression. Katsuki just took in the sight of him for a few moments, noticing how his chest moved slowly with each breath he took and how comfortable he seemed to be in his bed. As if he belonged there.

He did belong there now.

“Hmm…”, Deku moaned softly in his sleep. Unconsciously, he moved closer to Katsuki, probably sensing his absence from their previously cuddling position, even though he was asleep.

Then, Deku’s hand brushed against Katsuki’s groin as he tried to get closer.

Katsuki’s eyes widened as he realized that: 1, Deku had just subconsciously palmed his groin area, and 2, which was the most mortifying bit of it all: he was already erect, even before Deku’s touch.

Katsuki jumped from the bed as if he had been burned, which sent a new wave of pain through his injury and woke Deku up. The boy blinked up at Katsuki with confusion and worry at his sudden movement, and, before he could catch a glimpse of Katsuki’s erection, the explosive boy turned and ran to the bathroom, slamming the door behind himself.

“Kacchan?!”, Izuku called, obviously concerned. To Katsuki, his voice sounded muffled and distant – he didn’t have the chance to grab his hearing aids before he ran into the bathroom.

Looking through the gap under the door, Katsuki saw Deku’s shadow approach the bathroom. They were no longer connected by an invisible bond that forced them to be together at all moments, but this little scene of Katsuki hiding in shame inside his bathroom while Izuku waited for him outside was a bit too nostalgic.

“I’m fine”, Katsuki called from inside the bathroom. “Go back to sleep”.

“What happened?”, Izuku insisted with a loud voice, worried. “Did you have a bad dream?”

Katsuki stared down at his erection. Even though he had been startled by Deku’s touch, it was still pretty much… well, erect.

“I said I’m fine, Deku, just leave me alone”, Katsuki said, trying his best not to sound too impatient. “I’m going to take a shower”.

Deku hesitated outside the door.

“Ok…”, he said eventually, begrudgingly.

Katsuki sighed in relief as he saw Deku’s shadow on the floor move away from the door, and he sagged against the wall, only now processing the pain of having moved too fast. He lifted up his shirt to stare at his bandaged wound on the mirror, and he was happy to see there was no blood marring the white gauze. He closed his eyes and leaned his head against the cool wall tiles, just breathing through the pain and discomfort for a moment.

His erection started to die down after a few moments of sitting and breathing, now that there were no hands there to stimulate it. Katsuki tried to wrap his mind around what had just happened, since this was all very new to him.

It wasn’t like he never had an erection before. Hell, he had managed to have one back at the hospital, during recovery, where nurses and doctors could walk in and see it under broad daylight. No, this wasn’t his first time around this sort of thing. The difference was that, before, he never felt particularly aroused by anything. No classmates or movie stars entered his fantasies, because he didn’t fantasize. Sometimes he’d wake up with a boner after a dream he couldn’t quite remember, and then the erection would die down and go away on its own. Katsuki never had to do anything about it. He never did anything about it.

Sometimes, he’d get nocturnal emissions, yeah. Those were annoying and kind of embarrassing, but he never told anyone about it or let anyone see it – he always made sure to wash his own clothes, and his messy underwear was no exception to this rule. He could never quite remember his dreams when this happened, but he was sure that, if they were really that important or relevant to his daily life, he wouldn’t have forgotten about them in the first place.

There had been one embarrassing time when his dad tried to have “the talk” with him. He started to explain how the male body worked and what its desires were, but Katsuki had cut him off right away. He had learned enough anatomy at school, thank you very much, and if he had any doubts, he could look up the answers on his own. He didn’t want his dad of all people, with his weird metaphors and his hesitant explanations, to give him a lesson on how his own body worked.

The real problem here – the real reason why he never bothered masturbating or doing something about his erections before they softened down on their own – was his own quirk. His quirk wasn’t only to sweat a nitroglycerin-like substance, or only to cause explosions. It was both. He literally caused explosions with his hands. And his sweat, just like nitroglycerin, was a highly unstable substance that was easily inflammable. He wasn’t about to risk exploding his own dick because he caused too much friction on it just to get off for a few moments. He knew better than to try that, and he could live his life pretty well without jacking off like most teenagers his age. He had always made a point to *not* be like everyone else, so he wasn’t humble enough to admit that he did take pride in not masturbating. It wasn’t a necessity for him, and he never thought twice about it.

Not until Deku. The fucker seemed to be his exception for everything, huh?

This was the second time that Deku had given him a boner. And the reason why Katsuki had been so startled to the point of running away and hiding in the bathroom was – the touch, the

light stroke, the second-long palm that Deku had accidentally and totally-not-on-purpose given him in his sleep, had felt *good.* Not good like having your back scratched or having the back of your neck kissed. Good as in *a sensation Katsuki had never felt before.*

And now that he was thinking about how good it had felt, his goddamn boner was back.

Katsuki took a deep breath and swallowed dry, trying to think of what to do. He couldn't tell if he was aroused or not, but if he went back out with a boner there was no way Deku wouldn't notice it and want to talk about it, because the nerd was a nosy little shit who had no idea how to keep out of other people's businesses. So Katsuki needed to find a way to handle this, because he definitely wasn't ready to talk about masturbation and boners with Deku just yet. Realizing he loved the idiot was already a bit too much on his plate so far, and sex? Sex was definitely not on his scope. Not now, not anytime soon.

Fuck, he had never even though twice about sex. He never took interest in it. And he didn't know he *could* be interested in it until Deku came along. But how should they do it? They were both boys, right, so there was no way…?

No, no. Of course there was a way. There had to be. But he would have to do a shit ton of research before he even though about the possibility of having sex with Deku. He wasn't about to stroll into this like a fucking amateur and risk embarrassing himself and his reputation by doing something wrong. Just like he was determined to be the best boyfriend in the fucking world, the same applied to sex, and he wasn't ready for it just yet. He needed more time, to think, to prepare, and to have this conversation with his boyfriend.

Future boyfriend. He hadn't asked him that yet.

God, Katsuki had almost ruined a perfectly planned first-date night because of his dick. What an idiot.

All right. He needed to bring his boner down without jerking off. He got back to his feet, supporting himself with a hand against the wall and the other pressing down on his throbbing injury. He removed the bandages and the gauze that were covering the stitches and discarded them on the sink, taking a look at the injury's reflection on the mirror.

It still looked pretty bad, and it would definitely leave a scar – on his abdomen and on his back. The sight of it made Katsuki shiver, and his boner went from a hard-rock erection to a half-hard one at the memory of pain and near-death. He decided that the cold shower he would take would help soften his member, but there was no reason why he couldn't help his own brain out and think about shit that definitely didn't arouse him.

So as he stepped into the shower and turned on the cold water, he started to think thoughts that didn't turn him on at all. Grandmas. Someone puking. Breasts. A dog dry-humping someone's leg. Icy Hot. Icy Hot thirsting after Deku.

And then there was Deku, entering his mind again. Katsuki closed his eyes as water ran down his back and his limbs. Deku moaning softly as they cuddled. Deku's parted lips. Deku's warm tongue, caressing his bottom lip as they kissed. Deku sitting on his lap as they sparred. Deku kissing the back of his neck and sending goosebumps to his skin.

Fuck. Fuck, his erection was coming back. Grandmas. He needed to think about grandmas, goddamn it! Naked grandmas. His parents kissing. Inko. Round Face. Shitty Hair burping the alphabet. Two cats screaming their asses off in the middle of the night. That gross ear scene from NBC's *Hannibal*. Blood! Blood and pus and all sort of gross humanly discharges. Principal Nezu wearing nothing but a bowtie. A compound fracture. Anything!

His erection started to go down again, and it seemed that this time it was for good. Katsuki put all of his energy on not thinking about Deku at all, his eyes squeezed shut from concentration.

God, he felt pathetic. How could he lose control of his own body like this? He was supposed to be better than a horny teen that got hard just because a hand brushed him. For fuck's sake!

After washing himself properly and still going through the mantra of *grandmas, blood, burps, Principal Nezu, myiasis, abscesses,* Katsuki stepped out of his shower and dried himself. He hadn't brought clean clothes with him inside, so he would have to step out wearing a towel… Which was definitely risky, in case his lower half decided to start acting up again. He'd have to make a quick exit and an equally quick comeback.

Taking a deep breath, he wrapped the towel around his waist and opened the bathroom door. He usually wouldn't mind stepping out naked – he'd been naked around the boys from his class before –, but he wasn't really ready for Deku to see him with a boner – not until he had control of the situation and the slightest clue of what he was doing. So he rushed to the wardrobe to grab himself clean clothes and ignored the way Deku stared at him from where he was sitting cross-legged on the bed.

"Kacchan?", he called, still sounding worried, but Katsuki made sure to keep his back turned to him and to shoot out a quick:

"I'm fine. Just naked. Be right back".

Then, he rushed back into the bathroom and closed the door again.

He changed into the first clothes he had managed to grab, and then he stared at himself in the mirror. He knew Deku would want to know what had happened, and if Katsuki had to be honest, he knew the boy was in the right. If Deku had pulled this sort of scene at him, he would demand to know the cause, too. But like he had come to conclude, he wasn't ready to have the sex talk just yet. He didn't want to lie to Deku either, because he was no fucking liar, but he'd have to come up with something to tell him until he was ready to admit that Deku had made him hard with just a touch.

He walked back out of the bathroom, in no rush this time. Deku eyed him with expectation from the bed, and accompanied him with his eyes as he walked back towards him. Katsuki sat down on the bed, his back turned to Deku.

Katsuki put his hearing aids on and then proceeded to lie down slowly, careful not to disrupt his injury any further, and turn towards Deku. He gave the sitting boy a stern look.

“It’s too early for us to be awake”, he said simply, pulling Deku by the arm into a lying position beside him.

Deku raised an eyebrow at him.

“I thought you were the one who liked to wake up before the sun rises”, he nestled beside him.

“Not on Sundays, and not during recovery. I only wake up early when I want to work out, but I can’t really do that now, can I?”, Katsuki debated.

Deku gave him a look.

“Are you going to tell me what happened?”

Katsuki sighed.

“I needed to take a shit”, he lied. “Are you going to make me a bathroom schedule or something? Do I need your permission to take a piss too?”

The room was dark, but Katsuki could see the way Deku blushed at this.

“I’m… sorry”, the boy said. “I didn’t mean to intrude. I was just…”, he bit his lower lip. “I thought it had something to do with your injury”.

Katsuki reached out and took Deku’s hand into his. The gesture, which had taken him years to overcome, was now as simple and familiar as home.

“You don’t need to worry so much”, Katsuki said, intertwining his fingers with Deku’s. “I’m here. I’m fine. I’m getting better each day”.

Deku shifted on the bed so that he was face-to-face with Katsuki. They continued to hold hands.

“I know”, Deku smiled, but it fell from his lips quickly. “I don’t mean to pressure you or anything”, he admitted. “I just… I don’t want to lose you”.

Katsuki nodded.

“You’re not losing me when I go to the bathroom. And before you complain I killed the mood, I’m gonna say that I don’t want to lose you either”.

Deku snorted a little laugh through his nose.

“Sorry for worrying too much”, he said.

“I get where you’re coming from”, Katsuki reassured him. “I worry about you too, nerd”.

Deku sighed.

“How are we going to have a hero career like this?”

Katsuki frowned.

“What are you talking about?”

Deku shrugged.

“I don’t know if I’ll be able to work properly without you by my side. I’ll just worry about you 24/7”.

Katsuki scowled at him, self-deprecating.

“What great trust you have in my self-defense abilities”.

Deku closed his eyes and shook his head. He leaned forwards and placed a kiss on the tip of Katsuki’s nose.

“You know that’s not what I’m talking about”, he said gently.

“What *are* you talking about, then?”, Katsuki raised an eyebrow.

“You’re great at combat, and at quirk use, and at self-defense. I don’t doubt that. And I know that, when you face an enemy, you’re hellbent to win. And you always win. But, sometimes… like at training camp, and back at the museum. Sometimes, you get hurt when you win. And I don’t think I can go back to sitting at hospital wait rooms waiting for permission to see you’re still alive. It eats me inside”.

Katsuki continued to watch him. When Deku stopped talking, he let go of his hand and cupped his face in his hand gently instead.

“If you’re asking me to lose”, he said, “I have to let you know I can’t do that”.

Deku sighed.

“I’m not asking you to lose”.

“What are you asking me, then?”, Katsuki insisted.

Deku gazed at him with sincere eyes.

“Be with me”, he said.

“I am with you”, Katsuki responded.

“No. Be with me, forever. Be my boyfriend”.

Katsuki stared blankly at Deku.

His face started to scrunch up in an angry scowl.

“Son of a *bitch*”, Katsuki barked.

His reaction, as expected, hit Deku with a wave of surprise.

“W-What?”, he asked, confused by the angry reaction.

“Why did you have to go and ask me before I asked *you?*”, Katsuki demanded, furious. He removed his hand from Deku’s face and the boy sat up on the bed, frowning.

“What? You were going to ask me?”, he asked, startled.

“Of fucking course, *idiot*”, Katsuki said, angry. “I had a whole first date planned out to ask you, but now you fucking ruined it!”

Deku smiled and giggled at Katsuki, but noticing how genuinely angry he seemed to be, he backed off.

“We can still have a first date, Kacchan”, Deku offered, smiling compassionately. “We can even pretend I didn’t ask you to be my boyfriend. Ok?”

“What’s the use of pretending, Deku, you bastard?”, Katsuki scoffed. “We both know who asked first. We’ll both know that for the rest of our lives!”

“So you’re saying yes?”, Deku asked hopefully. Katsuki glared at him.

“What?”

“You want to be with me for the rest of our lives?”, Deku asked. There was sincerity and fear in his tone.

Katsuki rolled his eyes and pulled Deku closer to himself, a bit too aggressively. Deku collapsed on his side and Katsuki cuddled him from the behind, trying his best to keep his groin-area as far away as possible from Deku’s backside in case his lower half started acting up again.

“Of course I want to be with you, idiot”, Katsuki said. “Didn’t I say it already? How many times do I have to repeat myself?”

Deku laughed nervously; Katsuki felt it more than heard it, from the way his hand was splayed against Deku’s chest.

“In my defense, I did ask you about it right now and your answer was to call me a son of a bitch”, Deku pointed out. Katsuki rolled his eyes again, even if Deku couldn’t see it.

“Because I wanted to have asked you first. But you went and got ahead of me”.

Deku twisted his head back a bit so that he could look at Katsuki’s face.

“Not everything has to be a competition between us, you know”.

“It’s not a fucking competition”, Katsuki complied. “But I still wanted to be ahead of you”, he admitted, grumpy.

“Kacchan”, Deku giggled. “There’s no ‘ahead’ in a relationship. If we’re going to do this, we have to do it together”.

Katsuki sighed. He pulled Deku closer to himself and buried his nose on his shoulder.

“Shut up and let’s go back to sleep”, he said. The meds he had taken were starting to make him sleepy again. “Then we can have our first date, and *then* you can call yourself my boyfriend”.

Izuku giggled again, but Katsuki felt him nodding at him.

“All right, Kacchan”, he agreed. “Whatever you say”.

“Damn right”.

When Katsuki woke up, Deku was gone. There was a little folded paper sitting on the top of Katsuki’s laptop, so when he got up from his recovery morning nap, he found it and opened it.

*Went training with All Might. Want to have lunch together? Text me when you wake up ^_^*

Love,

Izuku

Katsuki rolled his eyes and set the note down. He grabbed his phone.

From: Kacchan

Yes to lunch. Text me when you’re done with All Might.

He then opened his chat with Kirishima.

From: Best Friend

So, we kind of have a problem

From: Shitty Hair

Uh oh

From: Shitty Hair

Did Midoriya find out about your top-secret plan of asking him to become his boyfriend?

From: Best Friend

…

From: Best Friend

Now how the fuck did you know about that?

From: Shitty Hair

Lucky guess

From: Best Friend

As fucking if

From: Best Friend

Tell me the truth

From: Shitty Hair

Fine. In my defense, it was Midoriya's fault

From: Shitty Hair

He spilled the secret to his friends, which also happened to be my friends, since I am friends with everyone

From: Shitty Hair

And now everyone kind of knows

From: Shitty Hair

I haven't told him anything about him, though

From: Shitty Hair

Despite his insistence

From: Shitty Hair

So at least part of this is still a surprise

From: Shitty Hair

But I kind of want to know how he learned about it

From: Shitty Hair

I didn't think you would have told him or anything, so I'm really curious

From: Best Friend

The fucker had the audacity to ask me to be his boyfriend before I asked him

From: Best Friend

I couldn't exactly say no to his face just because I wanted to be the first one to ask

From: Best Friend

So I told him about the plan

From: Best Friend

But I didn't tell him about the whole thing either. He just knows it's gonna happen

From: Shitty Hair

Oh, good

From: Shitty Hair

Then it's still up, right?

From: Shitty Hair

Because I gave your mom my number and she's been texting me pictures of different tables all morning

From: Shitty Hair

I told her she should get whichever one she liked best but. She continued to text them to me

From: Shitty Hair

I also told her I could go over and pick it up with her, but she insisted on bringing it here herself

From: Shitty Hair

She's pretty invested in all this

From: Best Friend

She's an idiot.

From: Shitty Hair

Well, she's not the only one who's excited about this

From: Shitty Hair

Now that everyone knows about the big date, they're excited to see how it goes

From: Shitty Hair

It's become this sort of big Class 1-A event everyone wants to be a part of

From: Shitty Hair

Well, nearly 3-A

From: Shitty Hair

But I still like to call us 1-A. Who's gonna stop me?

From: Best Friend

Fuck off. This is no event

From: Best Friend

This is between me and Deku

From: Best Friend

If anyone tries to pull paparazzi on us I'm blowing their asses off

From: Best Friend

Bye

From: Shitty Hair

Message duly noted

From: Bakugou

I need a favor

From: Ears

No need to tell me. Let me guess

From: Ears

You need me to make a playlist for you and Midoriya's not-so-secret first date

From: Bakugou

Fuck you.

From: Bakugou

But yeah.

From: Ears

Say no more

From: Ears

https://open.spotify.com/playlist/2Rv2OnP5ug9SEe9s7pKkbd?si=FJekmbGGSeSDivRKW32xqA

From: Bakugou

How the FUCK did you have that ready?

From: Ears

My bonus quirk is being the god of playlists. I thought we'd talked about this

From: Bakugou

Fuck's sake.

From: Ears

Is this “thank you” in Bakugou language?

From: Bakugou

Yeah

From: Ears

You’re welcome

Seen

From: Bakugou

Now wait a fucking second

From: Bakugou

Why is there only one song on this playlist and why is it George Michael’s Careless Whisper?

From: Bakugou

Are you shitting me

From: Ears

To be fair, yes

From: Ears

But I was hoping you’d only open the playlist on the date

From: Ears

Having you open it beforehand kind of ruined my joke

From: Bakugou

Your joke sucks and you’re useless

From: Bakugou

Bye

From: Ears

Aaahh come on don’t be upset

From: Ears

Do you want me to make you a proper playlist? Because I can totally do that. I can even add Spiritbox since you liked it so much

From: Ears

I can add the three parts of The Mara Effect

From: Ears

And every other song they've ever recorded

From: Ears

How about that?

From: Bakugou

Forget about it, the playlist idea is cheesy anyway

From: Bakugou

Bye

From: Brat

Since you're so insistent on being involved in this, I need you to bring something else. Call me when you can.

From: Best Friend

Forgot to tell you one thing

From: Best Friend

Let me know when you have the table ready. I don't think there'll be anyone at Ground Beta today, so I want to settle things up already. Don't wanna risk anything going wrong

From: Best Friend

Also since my mom's coming over to bring the damn table and some other stuff I'll ask her; I need you to do me another favor

From: Best Friend

This date isn't going to suck ass just because Deku found out about it

From: Best Friend

So I'm going even more plus ultra, since you bastards want to be involved so much

From: Best Friend

Hear me out

Best Friend is typing…

Best Friend is typing…

Best Friend is typing…

"So, when's our first date?", Izuku asked curiously.

Katsuki rolled his eyes and took a bite of his food before he replied.

"You'll know when you have to know", he said simply, not looking at Izuku.

Izuku pouted.

"Don't be mean", he reprimanded, half-hearted.

Katsuki huffed through his nose.

"How is planning out a fucking awesome first date being mean?", he inquired.

Izuku took a bite of his own food before replying.

"I'm really curious", he admitted. "I mean, I didn't have… When I asked you to be my boyfriend, I didn't have any big plans in mind. I just wanted to let you know how I felt. But now, seeing the effort you're putting into this… I feel kind of bad".

Katsuki frowned. "Bad" was the opposite of the reaction he'd been aiming for.

"Why?", he questioned, concerned.

Izuku shrugged.

“I didn’t plan anything big, like you did. I just said what was in my mind”.

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“So much for saying this wasn’t a competition”.

Izuku tapped his leg with his foot beneath the table, in what was meant to be a light reprimanding kick.

“It *isn’t* a competition. I just wish I had planned something nice for you, too”.

“You don’t have to plan shit”, Katsuki rolled his eyes. “I got it all ready”.

That seemed to upset Izuku further.

“See! That’s what I’m talking about”, he pouted, playing with his food instead of eating.

“Shut up and eat your damn food”, Katsuki reprimanded. “If you want to plan something so badly, save your plans for my birthday. The last one sucked ass, so I’m hoping next year’s will be better”.

A melancholic expression took over Izuku’s face.

“I…”, he hesitated. “I’m sorry”.

Katsuki raised a silent eyebrow at him, continuing to eat. Izuku bit his lower lip.

“I mean, I’m not sorry for being upset at you for calling me the Q-word. But, given everything that happened and all our arguments since… I’m sorry I gave you such a terrible birthday”.

Katsuki sighed.

“Water under the bridge”, Katsuki said simply. “We both fucked up on that day”.

Izuku gave him a tiny smile that seemed sadder than anything.

“Yeah, I guess”, he said, pensively.

With one final bite, Katsuki finished his lunch, whereas Deku had only eaten half of his own. He glared at the boy’s bowl, and then at his melancholic face.

“Stop looking so sad”, he reprimanded, dropping his *hashi* and crossing his arms above his chest. “What do I have to do to wipe that look from your face?”

Izuku smiled a bit more sincerely this time, but he didn’t meet Katsuki’s eyes. He continued to play with his food.

“Just being with you is enough”, he said softly.

Katsuki rolled his eyes again, sighing.

“Cheesy as fuck”.

“*Hey*”, Izuku narrowed his eyes at Katsuki, half-offended.

“Don’t try to deny it”, Katsuki said. “You’re one cheesy little fucker”.

“And you still want to date me”, Izuku accused.

“Yeah. I must be crazy or some shit”.

“Crazy about me, that’s more like it”.

“You bet”.

“I do”.

Katsuki smiled a crooked smirk at Izuku.

“Eat faster. I don’t want to stay here much longer”.

Izuku frowned.

“Why not?”

“The last thing I want is to risk running into my shitty nosy friends. Or worse, *your* shitty nosy friends. They’re about to arrive to have lunch any minute now, and I’d rather be left in peace”.

Izuku nodded. He stopped playing with his food and started to eat again.

“Wha’ are you goin’ to do today?”, he asked as he chewed. Katsuki thought for a while.

“Studying”, he lied. “I’m a little behind on the lessons. By the way, do you have those notes you said you were going to lend me?”

“I do”, Izuku nodded, eating. “I can give them to you later”.

“Good”, Katsuki nodded back. “I can’t wait to go back to classes, though”.

“I miss you”, Izuku admitted. “It feels wrong, to be at class and have no one sit in front of me”.

“Yeah”, Katsuki huffed. “At least when you were a ghost you could still go to classes with me, even if you couldn’t take any notes. Why do I keep pulling the shortest straw in this shitty game?”

“You’ll be back soon enough”, Izuku smiled at him encouragingly. “Meanwhile, I can keep taking notes for you. I can even study with you, if you’re up for it”.

“You? Teaching me?”, Katsuki gave Izuku a teasing look. “As if”.

Izuku rolled his eyes.

“It wouldn’t be a big deal, you know”.

“I know”.

“Then why are you being difficult?”

“Because I like to see your face when I tease you”, Katsuki smirked. “It’s cute”.

Izuku blushed, lowering his head.

“K-Kacchan…”, he said, embarrassed.

Katsuki snorted out a humorous laugh.

“We can study together later”, he said. “But not today”.

Izuku narrowed his eyes at him.

“Why not?”

“Rack your brains”.

Izuku’s eyes shone.

“Is the date today?”, he asked, full of hope.

“I don’t know. Is it?”, Katsuki teased.

“*Kacchan*”, Izuku said pointedly.

“I’m not telling you shit. Figure it out yourself, since you’re Smart-san”.

Izuku sighed.

“You’re so mean to me”.

“I’ve been meaner”.

Izuku rolled his eyes.

“Yeah, I suppose”.

“Oi”.

“What? You said it first”.

“Fuck you”.

“You wish”.

Katsuki’s brain halted.

“What?”

“W-What?”, Izuku asked nervously, his face becoming as red as a tomato. It was obvious he hadn’t meant to say what he had just said. Katsuki figured he must be blushing too, because his face felt really hot out of a sudden.

“The hell did you just say?”, Katsuki asked, startled and surprised – enough so that he couldn’t quite keep the words from his mouth. He hadn’t expected Deku to be that bold, so that meant he must have heard him wrong. Right? There was no way Deku had just said that he wanted to fuck him, right?

R-Right?

“IjustrememberedIhavesomethingtodosoIgottagoseeyoulaterbye”, Izuku said fast, getting up from his seat and half-jogging to the exit of the cafeteria. It was only after he disappeared through the door that Katsuki realized the boy had left his half-eaten lunch behind.

“What a fucking idiot”, Katsuki mumbled to himself. He sat there, on his own, for a few more moments.

Only now that Deku was gone did he realize there were several other people at the cafeteria, spread through different tables. Now that Katsuki had no one to talk to, the low humming of their conversations started to seep into his perception. Katsuki hadn’t noticed their presence, not while he was with Deku. When he was with Deku, it seemed like the whole world halted, and only the two of them were the protagonists of their own stories. No one else mattered. Nothing else mattered. They were always the only people in the room for Katsuki’s heart. It had always been like this, even if before Katsuki’s sentiment had been negative.

He tried not to put much thought into what Deku had just said to him, but it was hard not to. Katsuki vaguely wondered if Deku had fantasized about him, too; if he felt as aroused by Katsuki as Katsuki seemed to feel by him. Did he touch himself? And if he did, did he think about Katsuki? How often? Was it good?

Katsuki didn’t know how it felt, since he had always feared trying and maiming himself on accident, but Deku didn’t have a potentially explosive hand. He could touch himself whenever he wanted, as many times as he wanted.

Fuck. Ok. He was in the middle of the damn cafeteria. He shouldn’t be thinking about Deku touching himself, not there. The mortification he’d feel at his school mates seeing him with a boner in the middle of lunch would be hard to live down.

With a tired sigh, he got up from his seat. His injury didn’t protest much at the movement, which was a good sign. Recovery was slow, but it was happening, and Katsuki couldn’t wait to go back to his normal training routine and his daily life. He couldn’t *wait* to get rid of that stupid cane.

He grabbed it and used it to support part of his weight, just to prevent putting too much strain on his healing injury. With one hand, he grabbed his and Deku's trays and discarded them at the appropriate place, before going back to his bedroom at the dorm as quickly as his injury and his cane allowed him to.

When Katsuki arrived at his bedroom, he discarded the cane and sat down on the edge of his bed. He wouldn't be staying there for too long.

From: Best Friend

Everything ready on your end?

From: Shitty Hair

You got it, bro

From: Best Friend

Good. I'll start preparations

From: Shitty Hair

I'll text you about our progress. Everyone's ready

Katsuki put his phone down and took a deep breath. Then, leaving his cane behind, he got out of his bedroom and headed down to the dorm's kitchen.

Izuku exited his bathroom with a flushed face and trembling legs. He still couldn't believe he had committed that Freudian Slip with Kacchan, of all people. The memory was mortifying and embarrassing. He grabbed his phone and checked to see if there were any new messages, but there were none. Which he found kind of weird.

He had been almost sure that Kacchan would have texted him with some sort of profanity, demanding to know what had happened for him to leave the cafeteria in such a rush. Ever since Kacchan had been cleared out of Recovery Girl's medbay, they always walked back to the dorm together, so Izuku's quick departure must have weirded Kacchan out.

Still, he tried not to think too much about Kacchan's silence. Maybe Izuku had embarrassed him into quietude, which was definitely a first. The thought of Kacchan blushing and shying at the mention of sex was endearing to Izuku…

He was really looking forward to their date, though. He still felt a bit guilty for having told Kacchan he wanted them to be together in the way he did. He should have thought about a plan to make a big gesture out of it, like Kacchan was doing. Instead, he decided to declare himself as they laid in bed doing nothing. Izuku should have known better than that.

But in a way, he felt so happy inside. Because Kacchan – his Kacchan, the boy who Izuku had admired his whole life despite everything, the boy who he had loved for so long –, was going through the effort of doing a big meaningful gesture for him. They had gone through so much; they had overcome so many difficulties – in their own relationship and in life in general – that going on an actual *date* with Kacchan sounded like words coming out of a dream. He had to be dreaming, right? There was no way this was really happening.

And above all, he had no idea what to do or how to behave. He had never been in a date before. He had seen it in movies, but movies weren't a proper comparison standard for him, were them? This was about Izuku and Kacchan. This was about them, together, on a date. So, should he just act normally, like he always did? Should they tease and provoke each other? Or should they be serious, and cheesy, and romantic? God, Izuku had no idea.

Maybe he should ask his mom about it. She knew more about this romance thing than he did. He could ask one of his friends, but he wasn't so sure if any of them had gone on a date before. Would they know about dating protocol more than his mom? Uraraka and Iida seemed more focused on school than on romance, and as far as Izuku knew, Todoroki hadn't never had the chance to have proper *friends*, let alone girlfriends or boyfriends. So yeah, his mom was a better option.

He knew he could trust her. That was why he told her about the kiss. Of course he'd been afraid of her reaction, which was why he decided to be a bit of a coward and tell her over the phone. But when she started showering him with praises and excited remarks about his happiness, Izuku decided that maybe he could be more honest with her than he had first thought. Maybe… Maybe she deserved to know all the secrets in his life.

But he couldn't tell her about One For All without endangering her, right? Because that was the fate of everyone who knew about the quirk. They became possible targets. Telling Kacchan had already been a risk, even if Izuku trusted him with his life… And he now knew that Kacchan trusted him with his life, too.

They were bound together, even before the villain's quirk hit Izuku – they were bound together from their childhood, and from Izuku's secret, and from Izuku's quirk. It was now not only his but Kacchan's too, just as much as Kacchan's quirk was his as well. Not to mention the fact that they could still feel what each other felt, now that Izuku's soul, quirk

and memories were back with him 100%. They had created a bond between them that could not be severed, a bond of friendship, of partnership, of love, and of death. Even if they fell apart, they would still be connected for the rest of their lives.

That knowledge was reassuring, in a way. It made Izuku's chest warm.

He was pulled away from his thoughts by his phone vibrating in his hand, and only then did Izuku realize he had spent a long time staring at nothing, letting his mind wander. Blinking as he stepped away from his haze, he stared at the phone.

From: Uraraka Ochako

Hi, Deku-kun! What are you doing?

From: Deku-kun

Nothing at the moment, Uraraka-san. Why?

Uraraka Ochako is typing…

Uraraka Ochako is typing…

Uraraka Ochako is typing…

From: Uraraka Ochako

Can you meet me and Iida-kun at the common room?

Izuku thought for a moment. He was still trembling a bit from his visit to the bathroom, but he no longer had a boner and his high was over now. He had meant to take his study notes to Kacchan, but he wasn't so sure he could look him in the eye just yet. Maybe he should step away for a while, let him forget about the embarrassing lunch conversation. He wasn't even sure when their date would happen… Kacchan had hinted him it might happen today, but maybe he had been misleading Izuku.

From: Deku-kun

Sure, I'll be right down

Izuku put his phone into his pocket and went to meet his friends.

“I’m telling you, the answer is 24”.

“I’m pretty sure it’s not, dude. It’s 22”.

“You’re both wrong. I got 32”.

“32? Get outta here! You’re clearly in the wrong, Mina”.

“No, I’m not! You can ask Yaoyorozu!”

“I don’t think this is the most appropriate time to say the answer I got was 79?”

“*79*?!”, Mina burst into laughter. “Oh my god, that’s so ridiculous!”

“Oi, watch it!”, Kaminari protested.

“We should totally ask Yaoyorozu”, Mina insisted. “What do you think, Midoriya?”

Izuku hesitated, eyes darting between his friends.

“Ah, I… I’m sure her answer will be right”, he settled for saying.

“That settles it!”, Mina declared, fishing up her phone. “I’m texting her to come down here”.

“What was your answer, Midoriya?”

“Uh, I don’t… remember?”, Izuku admitted with a half-smile. “I was kind of wondering why we’re out here, though”, he admitted, looking around the garden area they were seated at.

“Fresh air, dude!”, Kaminari explained, passing one arm around Izuku’s shoulders and pulling him into a half hug. He shook Izuku before letting go of him.

Izuku lowered his head for one moment before raising it again. He was sitting with Kaminari, Sero, Mina, Uraraka, Iida, and Tsuyu. They had gone through the effort of strolling around UA's campus as they chatted, and Izuku thought they were just hanging out and being buddies. But now, as they reached the third hour of staying out the dorms without actually leaving the school, Izuku started to grow suspicious.

Whenever his friends wanted to hang out, they did so at the dorms' common room. Why had they chosen this grassy ambient this time? They were almost reaching winter, and the air was starting to become chilly.

"Is this about Kacchan's secret date?", he eventually failed to contain himself and asked Kaminari, who immediately looked like he had been slapped in the face.

Mina overheard them, and before Kaminari could say whatever he was about to dumbfoundedly say, she jumped at him with two hands on his shoulders and smiled widely at Izuku.

"Now, now, Midoriya-chan, wherever did you hear about that?", she asked with a nervous smile that was trying to be confident. Knowing that she was nervous was enough to confirm Izuku's suspicions.

"He told me about it already", Izuku pointed out. Now, all the friends in the group had stopped talking and focused their attention on him. "I mean, he said he was taking me out on our first date. He didn't say when or where it would happen, but now I have a guess".

Mina's eyes shone brightly at this.

"So you don't know, huh?", she asked with a smile.

Izuku frowned.

"Uh, I think it's today, since you kept me from the dorms for hours", he said.

"Oi, oi, oi!", Kaminari protested. "We were just hanging out with you as a friend. Don't shrug our companionship off like that!"

"Ok, little Sherlock Holmes", Mina said. "Even if you know it *will* happen and *when* it's going to happen, that doesn't mean there's no surprise left! It only means it's up to us to keep what's left of the secrecy of Bakugou's plan!"

Izuku smiled awkwardly at her. He could tell her intentions were noble, even if he was a little jealous that she knew the whole plan and he didn't.

"Ok…?", he shrugged.

"Operation First Date can finally start, then!", Mina announced, getting to her feet and adjusting her askew clothes. "You stay here. Uraraka and I will be right back!"

"Wait, what?", Izuku frowned, but it was too late. Mina grabbed Uraraka's hand and the girls started to run away, Izuku couldn't tell where to. He tried to follow them with his gaze, but

Kaminari was quick to wrap his arm around Izuku's neck and pull his face back to Sero, Tsuyu and Iida's little circle on the grass.

"Midoriya, my man, I have to say", Kaminari started. "I'm so *relieved* you and Bakugou decided to go public about all this. If I had to keep that kiss a secret for any longer…"

"Kiss? What kiss?", Sero asked with interest. Izuku felt heat rise up to his face.

"Ok, so listen to this", Kaminari started, letting go of Izuku's neck and pointing both his hands at Sero. He seemed excited, but then he looked pensive. He turned to Izuku again. "Uh, it's ok if I share this, right? Now that everyone knows you and Blasty are an item?"

Izuku shrunk a little on himself. It was true that he had a lot of good friends now, but he had grown up friendless. He wasn't used to talking about such intimate things, and his relationship with Kacchan was definitely intimate. Well, for starters, he wasn't used to having a *relationship*, period. He didn't really know how to act about all this, and while he wasn't ashamed, he wasn't completely in his comfort zone, either.

"I don't know…", he said hesitantly, his face as red as a tomato. Kaminari, clueless about Izuku's discomfort, gave him his own version of puppy eyes, which only made Izuku feel even more out of his depth. "O-Ok, I guess…", he mumbled, gazing down and not meeting anyone's eyes.

Kaminari beamed up at this, even more excited now.

"Ok, so hear me out 'cause this is good!", he began, electric with anticipation. "There we were, right, me, Aizawa sensei, Uraraka, and the paramedics. We were dodging holes in the ground and climbing our way up the wreckage, and we needed to be super careful, you know, in case we ended up dislodging anything and causing the whole structure to collapse even further. Aizawa sensei and the paramedics were in the front, Uraraka and I were in the back. By the time we finished climbing we reached some solid structure we could walk on. But still, it was like, walking on eggshells or something, we still needed to be super careful because if we did dislodge something, we'd end up falling and getting trapped and that wouldn't really help anyone. So we keep walking slowly even though time was sensitive and I end up seeing the hole where Bakugou and Midoriya were trapped. So I call everyone, right, but since I'm the closest I go ahead and climb down the hole, and when I get there – dude. Dude. When I get there, I see, with my own two eyes, Bakugou *French kissing* the hell out of Midoriya. Dude! I'm not joking! I'm not *joking*!"

"We know, kero", Tsuyu said, her index finger resting on her chin. She seemed interested in the story.

"I mean, can you *imagine*? Ok, ok, I know everyone knows they're together now, but dude? Imagine being the first person to see it? Imagine you're friends with the two of them, and you know, right, you know they haven't spoken to each other in what, half a year? And then you walk into a rescue mission after you nearly die on a terrorist attack and then you see this? Knowingly-rivals Midoriya and Bakugou, the two dudes who hated each other and kept fighting all the time, and they're *kissing???* What the hell was I supposed to think??? And ok, I didn't even have the time to think about anything because Bakugou was literally

impaled, so we had to help with the evacuation and then all that traumatizing stuff happened, but later, after everything, when I stopped to finally think about everything that had happened, I realized that? I saw two of my friends kissing? And like, the moment seemed to be super intimate and special to them, so I obviously couldn't tell anyone. And then Midoriya comes up to me and asks me to keep it a secret. And sure, I might be stupid but I'm not evil, so I keep it to myself. Imagine! Imagine this, you *know* Bakugou, he's your friend, and knowing Bakugou and being his friend, you *know* he's not the type to go around French kissing people even though he's super gorgeous, but then you go and you *see* him French kissing someone with your own two eyes, and it's not just anyone, it's his former-childhood-friend former-rival! Do you know how crazy that was?"

"I would say it's indeed surprising", Iida provided seriously, arms crossed above his chest. "But Midoriya-kun doesn't seem too comfortable with the story".

Izuku's eyes widened in embarrassment and he shrunk harder on himself, blushing even more intensely. He hugged himself and buried his face in his arms, looking away, embarrassed.

"I-It's ok, guys", he said. "I… I don't really… mind…"

"Oh, come on!", Kaminari said, tapping his back. "You don't need to be so embarrassed. Oh, look, the girls are back!"

"Don't let him look, don't let him look!", Izuku heard Mina's voice saying from the distance, and just as he was about to turn his head and look at them, Kaminari shoved his hand in front of his eyes.

"Huh?!", Izuku said in surprise, hearing Mina's and Uraraka's footsteps approaching. Kaminari pressed his hand harder against his face, so Izuku just sat there without a clue of what was happening.

"Iida, you have a mission", Mina announced, now closer to them. "Since you're the class representative and you're the most responsible of us all, I bestow you with the solemn duty of taking Midoriya to the man's common bathroom and helping him change into these clothes".

Izuku shifted his head in the hope of sneaking a peek on the clothes he was meant to wear, but Kaminari's hand was relentless. What clothes were they? Where had the two girls even taken them from?

"Deku-kun, close your eyes", Uraraka said softly from behind Izuku, which surprised him. He hadn't seen her approach, and he hadn't expected her to be so close.

"Huh? Why?", he asked, confused.

"Just do it", Uraraka instructed, and there was something off about her voice. It sounded more serious than usual, but also gentler.

"Ok", Izuku said, doing as he was told.

He felt Kaminari remove his hand from his face and resisted the urge of opening his eyes and taking a peek at the girls. Instead, he kept his eyes closed and felt something – some sort of fabric – being placed in front of his eyes. Uraraka was tying a makeshift blindfold behind his head, holding it securely into place in front of his eyes.

He opened them, and saw nothing.

“There”, Uraraka said triumphantly. “He’s all set!”

“Uraraka-san! What is the need behind this?”, Iida questioned, voicing one of Izuku’s own concerns.

“Bakugou wants to keep at least one surprise, since Izuku learned about the date when he shouldn’t know anything about it”, Mina explained. “He asked me to take care of it, so that’s what I’m doing!”

“Why do my own clothes have to be a secret?”, Izuku asked.

“Shhh, don’t argue with my plan!”, Mina said, poking his shoulder. “Now you go with Iida and change into these”, she handed the clothes to Izuku. “And don’t take a peek or else you’ll answer to me!”, she added in a warning tone.

“Let’s go, Midoriya-kun”, Iida said, touching Izuku’s elbow. “I’ll guide you!”

“Wait, we’re coming too!”, Sero shouted after them as they began walking.

Soon, Izuku felt two presences beside him, and someone – he assumed it was Kaminari – intertwined one of his arms with Izuku’s own. Iida continued to nudge his elbow as if to direct him to the right path, and Izuku had to say – the makeshift blindfold Uraraka had put on him was working. He couldn’t see anything, and if it wasn’t for his friends, he’d be completely lost.

“Ah, man, I’m so excited about all this”, Kaminari cheered, nudging Izuku’s arm.

“You seem more excited than Midoriya”, Sero commented.

For some reason, that bothered Izuku. He frowned, but his friends couldn’t see it from beneath the cloth covering his eyes.

“What do you mean? I’m excited”, he protested.

There was a pause.

“Uh, sorry man”, Sero said. “It’s just, you seem pretty nervous”.

“Yeah”, Kaminari agreed. “You’re shaking like a leaf”.

Izuku felt cornered.

“Iida-kun?”, he asked for support.

“I have to say that you do seem to be trembling, Midoriya-kun”, Iida provided with sincerity.

Izuku worried at his lower lip.

“It’s just…”, he started saying as they walked, relying completely on his friends’ guidance. Like this, blindfolded and depending on his trust on them, it felt easier to admit to his fears. It wasn’t so hard to be honest when he couldn’t look them in the eyes and see their reactions. “I never went on a date before”, he admitted, embarrassed.

There was silence.

“Me neither”, Iida admitted solemnly.

“Same”, Sero said easily.

“Ditto”, Kaminari provided, sounding the most embarrassed of the four.

Izuku swallowed dry.

“I – I just… I don’t know how to act. Or what to do. I’m… I’m worried I might screw things up”.

“Dude, don’t think like that”, Kaminari provided. “You’ll ace it, just trust me”.

“Yeah, Midoriya”, Sero backed him up. “Dating isn’t a school subject. You can’t take notes and ask questions and have all the right answers memorized so you don’t screw up. I know you’re used to having your notebooks around, but that’s just not how it works. All you gotta do is act as you normally would around Bakugou”.

“I agree”, Iida said. “Not that I have any experience on the matter, but Sero-kun’s suggestion seems to be very reasonable”.

“Yes, I know, and I mean no offense with what I’m about to say, but you guys just admitted you never went on a date before”, Izuku said. “So… How do you know this will work?”

There was a pause.

“Look, man”, Sero said. “I don’t know how dates are supposed to work, but I know Bakugou and I know you”.

“Yes”, Izuku nodded, defensive, “And if you know us, you also know we fight all the time”, he pointed out.

“Ah, come on… Not all the time”, Kaminari tried to say. “I mean, it happens a lot. But it’s not all the time”.

“Dude, we know Bakugou”, Sero pointed out. “And we know for a fact that he’s never dated anyone, either. If he’s willing to date you, I’m pretty sure he’ll go out of his way to make sure you have a perfect time together”.

“Yeah, dude”, Kaminari agreed. “I mean, you know him longer than we do. You *know* that he doesn’t half-ass anything. I’m sure he’s planning the perfect date right now, so just chillax and everything will be fine”.

“That’s the problem”, Izuku pointed out, desperate to be understood. “*He’s* always aiming for the top. *He’s* always perfect at everything. What about me? What if I screw up, what if I say the wrong thing and end up getting in an argument with him? What if I ruing the perfect date he planned?”

“Oops, hold on, there’s a step ahead of you”, Kaminari warned. Izuku lifted his foot blindly, searching for the step, and then he continued walking, guided by his friends. “There we are. We’re at the bathroom”.

“I’ll comment on your self-deprecative remarks in a moment”, Sero promised. “But first, you have to strip”.

“W-What?”, Izuku asked nervously, feeling heat rise to his face.

“Come on”, Kaminari said. “We’ve all seen each other naked before. And it’s not like you’re going full nude, you’ll still keep your underwear”.

“S-Still”, Izuku stuttered. “It feels weird to get naked while I can’t see anything and you guys can”.

“Take your shoes off”, Sero instructed. Izuku lowered himself hesitantly, until he was touching his shoestrings. He undid them and kicked the shoes off, feeling the cold floor of the common bathroom seep into his socked feet. “Good, now your shorts”.

Izuku hesitated.

“S-Sero-kun…”

“I can guarantee your modesty will be preserved, Midoriya-kun!”, Iida provided.

“Ok, fine, jeez, no one’s looking at you”, Sero promised. “We all have our backs turned. Go on”.

Izuku continued to hesitate, but he lowered the zipper of his shorts with shaking hands and let them fall to his ankles, then, he kicked them off.

“O-Ok”, Izuku announced.

Something was pushed into his hands, and he held the fabric, trying to recognize what piece of clothing it was just by touch.

“These are your new pants. Put them on”, Sero said.

Izuku swallowed dry and tried to feel for the leg holes of the pants. He also felt for the zipper so that he could tell which side was the front. With only a bit of stumbling, he put the pants on, closing them and buttoning them up.

“All right”, he announced.

“Good. Now shirt”, Kaminari instructed. Izuku felt a bit more comfortable about taking his shirt off than about taking his shorts off, so he easily removed the clothing and let it drop to the floor. “Here”, Kaminari handed him his new shirt right away. “Put it on”.

Izuku did as he was told. He could feel it was a dress shirt with buttons, so he started to button it up on his own, even though he was blind. Kaminari – the person closest to him – clicked his tongue and batted Izuku’s hands away from the buttons with dismissal.

“Here, let me”, Kaminari said, starting to fasten the buttons himself. Izuku supposed that would have a better outcome, since Kaminari could see whereas he could not.

“I’ll put your tie on”, Sero said from behind Izuku, passing something – which he assumed was the tie – around Izuku’s neck and starting to fiddle with it.

“I don’t have any task”, Iida pointed out, wanting to be useful.

“You can watch the door and make sure no one comes in”, Kaminari said.

“Uh, why, though?”, Sero pointed out. “What happens if someone comes in?”

Kaminari stopped buttoning Izuku’s shirt up, pensive.

“You’re right”, Kaminari said, going back to the buttons. “Uh, I don’t know then. You can scold Midoriya for thinking he’s going to screw up his date”.

“That’s a nice task”, Iida recognized. Then, straight to business: “Midoriya-kun. You shouldn’t think so low of yourself”, he scolded.

“Iida-kun…”, Izuku said, but it was half-hearted.

“Though I agree that you and Bakugou-kun go toe to toe very often, I must also recognize that you know each other very well. Well enough to know each other’s preferences and each other’s pet peeves”.

Izuku worried at his lower lip.

“Just do your best to not rile Bakugou-kun up, and there’s no way the date can go south”.

Izuku let out a shaky breath.

“O… k?”

“Look, dude, we get that you’re nervous”, Sero said in addition, finishing to tie Izuku’s tie up. “But like Iida said, you’ve known Bakugou since you were kids. You know what annoys him, and you know your way around him. I know you do. If he’s going through the trouble of planning this date, it’s because he really likes you. As long as you like him back, everything will be fine. So just do your best and be yourself. That’s enough”.

“Yeah. Being yourself is enough”, Kaminari mirrored. He finished buttoning Izuku’s shirt up and tapped his shoulder to indicate he was done. “There. You’re looking like a hundred bucks”.

Izuku continued to bite at his lower lip. He was grateful for his friends’ advice, but he still couldn’t help but to feel nervous.

The worst part was that he *knew* there was no reason to feel this way. This was Kacchan. Like they had said, Izuku had known him all his life. He would even dare to say that he knew Kacchan better than anyone. Now that he had his memories back from his time as a ghost, he would also dare to say that he knew exactly how to act around him.

And yet, fear gnawed at his stomach. Fear that he would say the wrong thing with the nicest of intentions, and start yet another meaningless fight. Fear that he would offend Kacchan after he went through all the trouble of making such a special date for them. Fear that he would ruin things to the point of setting their relationship back to its beginning stage, back to when they were rivals and nothing else, nothing more.

If Izuku had to be honest, he was afraid of losing Kacchan again. It always seemed to be like this, between the two of them: they’d take one step forward, two steps back. This date was the step forward. Which meant the two steps back were approaching in the horizon.

But did it have to be like this? Hadn’t they broken the cycle of shame? Hadn’t they grown, after what happened at the museum, and after all of Izuku’s visits back at Recovery Girl’s medical bay? After all the nearly-scripted conversations they had shared, after everything Izuku said, after they kissed and kissed and kissed again? After they slept side by side, cuddling each other? After he was allowed to see a side of Kacchan that no one else in the world had seen before? After Kacchan admitted that he loved him?

Izuku felt blessed. He *was* blessed. And maybe he should have a more optimistic approach to all this. He was basing his fear on previous experiences without taking it into consideration that he hadn’t taken only one step forward with Kacchan, he had taken several. Twenty steps forward and one step back was still nineteen steps forward.

And besides that, they had made a promise to each other: that they would try to trust each other more, and be more honest with each other. By being consumed by fear, Izuku was backing down on his promise. And he was a man of his word.

He wouldn’t back down.

He stayed silent as his friends guided him out of the bathroom. His sense of direction was a bit haywire, so he couldn’t tell if they were going back to their little circle on the grass or if they were going another way entirely. He heard some familiar voices approach them as they walked, and soon enough he could recognize Mina, Uraraka and Tsuyu. Back to the circle, then.

“There he is! What a sight!”, Mina cheered.

“Y-You look *sugoi,* Deku-kun!”, Uraraka said, seeming nervous.

“Those are nice clothes, Midoriya-chan”, Tsuyu added.

“We did a fine work, ‘aight, fellas?”, Kaminari took pride, leaning his elbow on Izuku’s shoulder.

“You took longer than we did”, Mina pointed out.

“What? No, we didn’t!”, Kaminari protested.

“Yes, you did!”, Mina echoed.

“You already had makeup on, all you had to do was strip and dress into those fancy dresses! Try helping a guy who can’t see dress himself without looking at him because he’s too embarrassed about being naked”, Kaminari pointed out.

“I have to agree with Kaminari-kun on this”, Iida admitted.

“Uh, guys?”, Izuku asked, still unable to see anything. “What are you even arguing about?”

“You’re not the only one who gets to dress up fancy for your first date”, Kaminari said.

Izuku frowned.

“What do you mean?”, he asked.

“Dude, this is bigger than the festival. This is bigger than anything we’ve seen!”, Sero cheered excitedly.

“Ok, ok, so, we’re Bakugou’s buddies, right”, Kaminari said. “We get to make fun of him and talk shit about him. You won’t get offended, right, Midoriya?”

Izuku frowned.

“Uh, I don’t think I know what you mean”, he admitted.

“I’m talking about *teasing*”, Kaminari explained, making kissing noises to the air. “Provoking him for becoming a romantic guy out of nowhere, that sort of thing”.

“I already told him it’s a bad idea, Midoriya”, Mina tried to say. “But he keeps insisting on it”.

“You’re the one who said you’re going to take pictures!”, Sero defended Kaminari.

“Uh…”, Izuku mumbled. “Do you mean you guys are going to watch the date?”

Silence.

“… Guys?”, Izuku’s frown deepened. He was literally in the dark.

“I agree with Midoriya-kun”, Iida pointed out. “Are you two intending on watching their date?”

“*No*”, Sero lied, at the same time Kaminari blurted out: “Uh, *yeah*, it’s not like you can stop us”.

“Ooh, jeez”, Izuku stuttered nervously, lowering his burning face in embarrassment.

“I must speak against this behavior!”, Iida reprimanded, sounding serious. “A date is supposed to be a private, intimate moment between a couple!”

“Dude, I’m sorry, but you’re not talking us out of this”, Kaminari argued, unaffected by Iida’s scolding tone. “Sero, Mina and I went through a lot of shit, it’s only fair we get to see our friends be cheesy and romantic for a change”.

“Yeah”, Sero agreed. “Plus, we all have a role to play”.

“A role?”, Iida questioned.

“*And* we’re not going to reveal anything because Bakugou went out of his way to preserve what was left of the secrecy of the plan”, Sero added.

“Yeah”, Kaminari agreed. “This is some Bakusquad sensitive, exclusive material”.

Izuku blinked, even though he couldn’t see anything.

“I’m so confused”, he admitted, helpless.

On one hand, he was really all happy and giggly inside because of all the efforts Kacchan seemed to be going through to surprise him, despite the way Izuku had found out about his plans for their first date. On another, he was pretty nervous about all this. He had no idea what was in store for him, and all this secrecy added to the possibility that things would be grand enough for Izuku to ruin everything.

“As you should be, you little zygote”, Kaminari ruffled his hair in a way that was similar to when Kacchan did it. “God, you grew up so fast”.

“Can you believe how far they came”, Sero joined him, sounding dramatic. “Wow, this has been such a journey”.

“We’re all the same age”, Izuku pointed out. “How am I a zygote?”

“That sounds a lot like All Might”, Iida commented. “But as Midoriya-kun’s friend, I must insist that you do not get in the way of his first date with Bakugou-kun”.

“We’re not getting in the way, class rep”, Mina said playfully. “We’re more like. *Getting* in the way”.

“How does that even work?”, Izuku frowned.

“Shh”, Kaminari shushed him. “You’ll know when it’s time to know”.

“Where are we even going?”, Izuku asked, but Kaminari shushed him again.

“You’re getting no answer out of us, Midoriya”, Mina announced. “So just stand there and wait for us to guide you. Think of this as a trust exercise!”

Izuku bit his lower lip.

“Uraraka-san? Iida-kun?”

“Yes, Deku-kun?”, Uraraka appeared beside him.

“Uh, you’re not telling me what’s going on either, are you?”, he asked hopelessly.

There was a pause.

“We’re not involved in the plan”, Uraraka provided. “Bakugou-kun made sure just his closest friends knew about it. We’re just here for support”.

“S-Support?”

“Yes”, Iida provided. “Your support”.

“You must be nervous, right? Deku-kun?”, Uraraka asked.

Izuku swallowed dry. Again, it felt easier to be honest with his eyes closed. He nodded.

“I figured”, Uraraka grabbed his hand. “I just… I just want you to know I’m happy for you”, she said, and Izuku figured her voice sounded a bit sad, out of a sudden. She squeezed his hand. “I hope Bakugou-kun is good to you”.

“He is”, Izuku said without hesitation. That fact was true in his heart. “He… Does his best”.

There was a small pause.

“Then *ganbatte*, Deku-kun!”, Uraraka forced herself to say before letting go of his hand.

“We’re here for you, Midoriya-kun!”, Iida announced, placing one hand on his shoulder. “I know you must be nervous, but you can rest assured everything will turn out fine”.

Izuku swallowed dry again.

“I’m nervous, but I know I shouldn’t be”, he admitted. “I mean… This is Kacchan. I know him. He knows me. I just…”, he shook his head.

“None of that self-deprecative talk, eh, Midoriya?”, Sero said with a warning, and his voice sounded distant, as if he had walked away from the group. Izuku, of course, hadn’t seen this, since his eyes were still blindfolded.

“A-All right, Sero-kun”, Izuku said loudly in order to be heard from afar. “A-All right”, he repeated to himself in a lower voice.

And then, someone appeared behind Izuku’s blind form, saying in a stoic voice:

“Bakugou must really like you”.

“T-Todoroki-kun!”, Izuku recognized with a jolt of surprise. He turned on his heels so that he could face his friend, even if he couldn’t quite see him. “I – I was wondering where you were”.

“I was trying to decide whether or not I’d take part on this”, Todoroki provided easily. He didn’t sound as sad as Uraraka or as tense and stern as Iida, but there was something off about his voice, something different that Izuku couldn’t quite identify. “I ended up reaching the conclusion that you’re my friend and I’d like to help”.

Izuku smiled softly at him.

“Thanks, Todoroki-kun”, he said sincerely. “I’m – I’m glad you’re here to support me”.

“Midoriya-kun!”, Mina shouted from the distance. “Come with us!”

“It’s time to go”, Uraraka said, and then she intertwined her arm with Izuku’s. Someone did the same to his other arm, and from the coldness, Izuku figured it must be Todoroki.

“Is it now?”, Izuku asked nervously, allowing his friends to guide him. “The date?”

“Just relax”, Uraraka told him gently, nudging at him gently.

They continued to walk, and Izuku didn’t know what to say to fill the silence. He usually spoke a lot when he was nervous, but this time – this time, he was rendered quiet and introspective. He had already voiced his worries and insecurities to Kacchan’s closest friends, and he knew that his own friends wouldn’t be so happy to witness his self-deprecation. There was no reason to be nervous. There was no reason to believe he would ruin things. It would be fine. *This will be fine*.

After a few minutes of walking, Todoroki and Uraraka started to slow down their pace, so Izuku did the same. Then, they untangled their arms from Izuku’s, which left him standing alone blindly in the middle of god knows where.

Everything was quiet. There were birds chirping in the distance somewhere, and the weather was getting chillier by the second.

“Guys?”, Izuku asked.

There was no response.

“Uh, are you guys still here? Can I take the blindfold off?”

No answer. Just birds and chilly wind.

Izuku sighed.

“All right, I’m taking it off”, Izuku announced – probably to no one –, reaching with his hands to the back of his head. “I hope this doesn’t spoil the…”

He looked around, finding he was completely alone.

"… surprise".

He was still inside UA. The place, the street, seemed familiar, but it went unnoticed by Izuku, whose attention was on the floor. There was something there in the middle of the road, and it looked suspiciously like a photograph.

Izuku bent down and picked it up. It was glued to the floor with duct tape so that the wind didn't send it flying away, but Izuku managed to retrieve it easily.

It was a photo of him and Kacchan as kids, playing together in their neighborhood's playground. They were so tiny that they couldn't have been older than two or three years old. Izuku didn't think his mom had a photo of them so young, so this must be Mitsuki's.

He turned the photo around and saw a neat handwriting on the back. It said: *Katsuki's new friend Izuku*.

Izuku felt his eyes burn.

He stood up and looked ahead of him. There seemed to be a series of photos scattered on the floor one after the other, up until the street's corner.

They were leading his way. Leading his way to Kacchan.

He looked around again for safe measure, trying to spot his friends, but they were gone. He was all alone, and it was up to him to find his way now.

He walked up to the next picture and bent down to pick it up. In this one, they were a little bit older, and Izuku quite frankly didn't remember the day it was taken. Kacchan was holding him up in the air, seeming to struggle to adjust Izuku's tiny weight in his grasp but keeping a victorious face all the same. Izuku, on the other hand, had his arms spread out triumphantly, as if wanting to put Kacchan's deed on display. They were both smiling widely, and Izuku found himself smiling at the photo too.

He continued walking and took the next picture. It was taken at Kacchan's 4th birthday. There were other children there with them, but Izuku was the closest one to the birthday boy – he was standing right behind him. He seemed terrified of the cake because of the number of candles there, and he was crying hysterically with his hands on his face, whereas Katsuki was pointing at the cake with an excited expression.

Izuku continued walking, and the next photo he found was still about the birthday. This time, Izuku had stopped crying, but he was staring at the cake with a somber look. Katsuki was trying to cut the cake without any adult supervision, and Mitsuki was slapping his hand away from it with a knife in her free hand.

The next photo showed Katsuki celebrating with his arms up while Masaru held him high, Mitsuki caught mid-eyeroll. Behind them, Izuku had a fat piece of cake in hands, and his mouth was open wide while he tried to fit the whole thing inside at once. Izuku couldn't help

but to laugh at the series of pictures, and his heart felt so warm and full that it seemed to be about to burst. His face scrunched up in a half-smile, half-sob.

The next picture was no longer about the party. It showed Katsuki and Izuku sleeping peacefully together on the same bed. Izuku was lying on a fetal position with his thumb in his mouth whereas Kacchan was spread on the bed, one of his legs resting atop Izuku's torso. There was a blanket with an All Might pattern hanging from the edge of the bed, and two All Might dolls at the bottom of the bed, near the two boys. The caption behind the photo said "Sleepover!"

The picture after that showed them at the neighborhood's playground again. Izuku was kneeling on the floor and Katsuki was atop him in a messy piggyback ride. They both had little makeshift red capes swinging behind their backs. The caption of the picture said "Playing heroes together", and Izuku found more tears beginning to pool on his eyes.

He turned on the street's corner, and then he recognized where he was. He should have recognized Ground Beta right away, even if he had been blindfolded along the whole way, but his attention had been on the pictures. They were all in his hand, nestled carefully above his chest. And there, from the corner of the street, he could see Kacchan and Kirishima, waiting by a small table for two in the middle of the road.

Izuku stared at them from the distance, and they stopped talking to each other, noticing his presence. They stared right back at him, waiting for him to make a move. Izuku lowered his head to stare down at himself, only now seeing what clothes he was wearing. It was a dark-green dress shirt and a pair of fancy black pants. They seemed to be brand-new. Izuku had no idea where they were from. Had Kacchan gotten them for him?

He started walking slowly towards Kacchan and Kirishima, because it didn't seem appropriate to run to them (like he wanted to). He didn't walk slowly, though. His steps were hurried and his heart was beating hard and fast inside his chest. He was smiling, and, the more he approached the pair of friends, the more rushed his steps became. At the end of it, he found himself jogging to them, and once he reached Kacchan, he dove straight in for a hug, pulling him close and burying his face on the crook of his neck.

"Idiot", Izuku said, voice muffled by Kacchan's clothes. He had a deep-red dress shirt on, a black waistcoat, and he was wearing a tie. Kacchan, wearing a *tie*.

"How am I the idiot if you're the one who's crying?", Katsuki questioned, holding Izuku in his arms.

Izuku pulled back from the hug so that he could give Kacchan a narrow-eyed look.

"You knew exactly what you were doing when you put out those photos", he accused, sniffing and rubbing his wet cheeks with the back of his hands. "You – You *know* how I get".

Katsuki smirked, seeming pleased with himself.

"If you think that's all, you'd better take a seat. Let me", he said, walking around the table and pulling a chair for Izuku.

“So we’re going to stay here in the middle of Ground Beta?”, Izuku asked. He walked to the opposite side of the table and pulled out a chair for Katsuki as well.

They just stared at each other.

“Uh”, Kirishima said awkwardly. Taking a better look at him now – so far, Izuku only had eyes for Kacchan –, he could see that the boy was dressed pretty much like… a waiter? “Let me get the chairs for the both of you”, he announced, going to Katsuki’s side first.

Katsuki clicked his tongue with disdain but accepted his friend’s offer, having Kirishima pull the chair for him and sitting down. It was better than waiting for Deku to make a move. Once he was settled, Kirishima walked up to Izuku and did the same for him.

“Well, I figured Ground Beta is symbolic as fuck to us”, Katsuki answered Izuku’s question.

Izuku placed the photos on the table, which was covered by a fancy looking tablecloth.

“You must have gone through a lot of trouble to bring a table out here”, Izuku commented, a smile on his lips. He was doing his best to put his admiration on display, lest he offend Kacchan on accident. “How did you even…?”

“Tch. You don’t need to focus on those type of details”, he said simply. “Just tell Shitty Hair what you want to eat already”.

Izuku blinked in shock.

“W-What?”

“All right, here’s the menu! *Monsieur*”, Kirishima provided, offering Izuku a folded sheet of paper. Izuku opened it, only to reveal the word “katsudon” written in all caps and covering the entirety of the paper.

Izuku smiled, looking up at Kirishima.

“I’ll have the katsudon, please”, he said humorously. “And I’m pretty sure Kacchan will have the same”.

“Don’t speak for me”, Katsuki reprimanded. “But yeah. I’ll have the katsudon”.

“All right”, Kirishima said, taking the sheet of paper back from Izuku and placing it beneath his armpit. “Two katsudons, coming right up!”

He turned on his heels and walked away, leaving the two of them alone together.

Izuku immediately turned to look at Katsuki, a fond smile on his lips. Before he could even begin to say anything, Katsuki spat:

“Before you complain about Ground Beta not being exactly the most romantic place on Earth, I’ll let you know Aizawa sensei prohibited me from leaving school grounds”, he said, grumpy. “Otherwise, this shitty date would be much better”.

Izuku smiled tenderly at him.

“Kacchan”, he said. “This is perfect”.

Katsuki huffed, rolling his eyes.

“I know I said Ground Beta is symbolic to us, and it is”, he continued. “But it’s still a shitty place to have a first date. Which is why I came up with the idea of using the pictures. I asked my mom to bring them over, along with this”, he knocked at the table.

“Where did your mom find the table?”, Izuku asked curiously.

“At a table store or some shit, I don’t know what table stores are called”, Katsuki said dismissively.

There was a pause.

“You *bought* this?”, Izuku asked, shocked. “Kacchan, you shouldn’t have! This must have been expensive – it’s – it’s solid wood –“, he bent down on his seat to look at the table from beneath the tablecloth.

“Shut up”, Katsuki said simply, leaning back against his seat and kicking Izuku’s leg from under the table. “Don’t tell me what I can or can’t buy. I wanted a proper table for our proper first date, so I went and I got it. That’s not the only thing I spent my money on”.

Izuku’s eyes widened at this and he sat up straight at the table again.

“W-What?”

“Two katsudons arriving!”, Kirishima reappeared, holding two fuming bowls of food.

“That… was fast”, Izuku commented, genuinely surprised.

“Thank Todoroki for that”, Kirishima said simply, not looking at Izuku as he placed the bowl in front of Katsuki. “The food was ready, all he had to do was give it a little warm up”.

“Oh”, Izuku blinked. He looked around trying to see Todoroki – or any of his friends, really – nearby, but he found no one. “And where is Todoroki-kun?”, he asked, looking at Kirishima.

“Oi, nerd”, Katsuki called, sounding offended and almost jealous. “Keep your eyes on me, you dweeb”.

“Sorry, s-sorry”, Izuku smiled. “It’s just – uh, I heard Mina-san talking to Sero-kun and Kaminari-kun, and they said they were going to… um…”, he hesitated, leaning a bit forwards on his seat so that Kacchan could hear his lowered voice. “They said they were going to watch the date”, he said, voice barely above a whisper.

Katsuki scoffed and rolled his eyes.

“It’s not what you think”, he began.

“What? So you knew?”, Izuku asked, surprised.

“They’re not going to watch like a bunch of stalking paparazzi, they’ll be our waiters”, Katsuki explained, gesturing at Kirishima. “I knew there’d be no way in hell I’d manage to keep them away from us during our date, so I let them help with this shit. At least they can’t take creepy photos of us while they’re busy serving us like the proper extras they are”.

“Oi!”, Kirishima complained.

“Shut up and do your job”, Katsuki said, but Izuku could recognize there was humor beneath his rough tone. “And you”, he turned back to Izuku. “Start eating before your food gets cold. You won’t get to warm it up again, I’m not letting Icy Hot anywhere near you tonight”.

Izuku stared at the bowl of katsudon in front of him. It looked delicious. He grabbed his *hashi* and took a bite of the food, his eyes widening as he chewed.

“Kacchan, *sugoi*”, he said, voice muffled. “You put less pepper than last time!”

Katsuki rolled his eyes again.

“Well, yeah, I can take constructive criticism, even if I don’t fucking like it or agree with it. Plus, I knew the photos would bring enough tears to your eyes, so I didn’t need my spices to add on that”.

Izuku narrowed his eyes at him with fake offense, but he continued to eat. Katsuki grabbed his own *hashi* to get started with his dinner as well, but then he noticed Kirishima was still beside him, waiting with the empty tray shoved beneath his arm.

Katsuki cleared his throat suggestively.

Kirishima looked at him.

“What?”, he asked, clueless.

Katsuki tilted his head to the side.

“Can I *help* you?”, he asked sarcastically.

“Huh?”, Kirishima frowned.

“The fuck are you still doing here?”, Katsuki asked more bluntly, raising his eyebrows.

“Oh”, Kirishima came to his senses, straightening himself up. “Right. I’ll – I’ll be on my way. It’s just, so weird, you know? Seeing how much the two of you grew. Seeing you hang out so well after everything”.

“We’re not *hanging out*”, Katsuki pointed out. “We’re having – or rather, *trying* to have a date. Which is composed by one, me, and two, Deku. You and our friends or any third party are not included”.

Kirishima nodded solemnly.

“Right. You’re right. Sorry, bro. Enjoy your date!”, he said, walking away with a pleased smile. Katsuki watched him go and shook his head in disapproval.

“That shit makes me angry”, he admitted.

Izuku frowned. He knew how pissed off Kacchan could get with small things, but Kirishima always seemed to know his way around the boy better than others. Izuku wouldn’t have expected Kacchan to be mad at such a small gesture from Kirishima, of all people.

“I think he meant well”, he tried to defend their friend. “I think they all mean well. They’re just – happy for us. You know?”

Katsuki huffed, his eyes downcast.

“If they’re so happy, why do they keep acting like I’m going to hurt you as soon as I’m left alone with you?”

Izuku lowered his *hashi*, staring at Katsuki.

“I don’t think that’s it, Kacchan”, he said sincerely. “I mean, I don’t think they think you’re going to hurt me. It’s just… our whole development, or at least the best part of it, happened while I was a ghost. They didn’t get to see that, only you did. You were the only one who could interact with me, after all. And then, after I woke up from the coma, there weren’t many instances in which we interacted in front of them, and even when we did, it was different because… well. I didn’t have my memories. And then, we stopped talking. And we stopped talking for *half a year*. From their side, all this – everything we’re both feeling – must have seemed pretty sudden”.

Katsuki did a nose scrunch.

“Yeah, whatever”, he said, a bit grumpily. “I just don’t want these assholes thinking I’d hurt or mistreat my own damn boyfriend”.

If Izuku had real bunny ears, they would have shot right up at this.

“Huh?”, he squealed.

Katsuki finally raised his eyes to meet his gaze.

“What?”, he asked mid-bite.

“B-Boyfriends?”, Izuku asked, a smile appearing on his lips. “We get to use that word now?”

Katsuki narrowed his eyes at him.

“Well, since we’re finally having a proper first date and all, I’d say so”, he said. “Unless you don’t wanna label it, which I find improbable”.

Izuku continued to smile, but he gave Katsuki a look.

“You know how much I like labels”, he said playfully.

Katsuki raised his eyebrows in agreement.

“Tell me about it”, he mumbled, continuing to eat.

“But you’re ok with it?”, Izuku asked a bit more seriously.

Katsuki stared at him again.

“If I wasn’t serious, I would have said anything”, he said simply. “There’s no point in telling you to use a word if that word makes me uncomfortable”.

It was Izuku’s turn to lower his head. He held his *hashi* in a tighter grip.

“I’m…”, he swallowed dry. “I’m very honored, Kacchan”.

Katsuki raised an eyebrow at him.

“For what? Being my boyfriend?”, he asked, half-serious, half-jesting.

Izuku nodded his head solemnly. He seemed very serious.

“And for having you as my boyfriend”, Izuku said. Then, he smiled hesitantly. “It makes me really happy”.

Katsuki nodded.

“I know”, he said, playing with his food for a moment. “It makes me happy, too”.

Izuku’s smile became wide.

“Really?”

Katsuki squinted.

“What, is it that hard to believe?”, he asked defensively.

Izuku rolled his eyes, but there was affection in the gesture.

“No”, he said. “Not anymore”.

Katsuki nodded. He seemed pensive, even as he went back to eating his own food silently. Izuku did the same and then there was a comfortable quietude between them; the only sounds in the street were made by crickets and faraway birds. The sun was about to set in the horizon, which meant the sky was tinted a mixture of purple, pink and orange.

“Penny for your thoughts?”, Izuku asked shyly after a while, when they were both half-done with their bowls of food.

Katsuki shrugged, distant and cold, and Izuku's stomach did a backflip at the reaction. Everything was going so well! But why did Kacchan seem so upset?

"Did I… do something wrong?", Izuku frowned, genuinely concerned.

Katsuki's head shot up at this, and he sent Izuku a confused look.

"What? No", he said. "Why the fuck would you think that?"

"I don't know!", Izuku exclaimed, defensive. "We were laughing and joking around, but then you went really quiet and –", he hesitated. Then, he sighed. "I just want us to have a nice time together", he concluded.

Katsuki worried at his lower lip.

"It's just…", he said. "I want *you* to have a nice time".

"I *am* having a nice time", Izuku smiled encouragingly at him.

"But I don't know how to do this", Katsuki admitted – which was rare for him. "I don't know if Ground Beta was a shitty idea, I don't know if you're just smiling to make me feel better. I mean, I can't tell. Because back then – even when I treated you like shit – you were always smiling at me when you saw me the next day. No matter what I did to push you away, you always came back with your stupid smile and your *sugoi*s and your admiration. And I don't want you to keep doing that. I want to know when I hurt you, so I can learn and put a stop to it".

Izuku stared at Katsuki with disbelief.

"Kacchan", he said, patiently. "You went out of your way, even if you're still recovering, just to give me a first date with you. You spent your money and your time on planning everything. You cooked for me, and you called me your boyfriend. There is no way in the *world* I could be unhappy right now".

Katsuki shook his head, not meeting Izuku's eyes.

"You have low standards", he accused.

"And you have an inferiority complex", Izuku accused right back.

Katsuki raised his head, glaring at Izuku.

"The fuck?"

To Izuku, everything seemed clearer now. His own fear, and Kacchan's, were very similar in nature.

"I'm just saying", Izuku shrugged. "Everything is perfect, and yet there you are, beating yourself up over a problem that doesn't even exist. Why does there always have to be a problem?", he asked gently, smiling.

Katsuki continued to glare at him, but Izuku saw acceptance in his eyes.

Izuku put down his *hashi* and reached out across the table. Katsuki hesitated before doing the same and grabbing Izuku's hand.

"Everything is *perfect*", Izuku said vehemently, smiling. "And I'm not saying this because I have low standards, I'm not lying to make you feel better. I'm saying this because it's true. I'm saying this because I love you, which means that whichever gesture you make me, however small, is going to get me to cloud nine. You make me happy".

"I also hurt you", Katsuki shot back. "A lot of times. Even when I was just trying to protect you, I hurt you. And I don't want to do that again. The worst part is – I don't even know when I do it".

Izuku nodded comprehensively.

"I'll tell you", he promised. "If you ever hurt me again, I'll let you know. We could go back to that thing where I say when you're being an asshole, it was pretty useful back when I was a ghost".

Katsuki huffed through his nose, humorous. He smirked.

"Yeah", he nodded. "That shit worked, even when I pretended it didn't".

Izuku nodded back with a smile and let go of his hand.

"If anyone should feel bad, that's me", he pointed out. "You went through all the trouble of making us a nice first date, and I didn't even plan anything. I mean, you said we were going to have the date, so I assumed you had everything planned and I didn't want to make up *other* plans that would end up getting in the way of *your* plans, but still… I feel like a useless boyfriend", he admitted with a shrug.

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

"Leave the chivalry to me", he said. "I don't want to be pampered by you".

Izuku raised his eyebrows.

"What? Why not?", he asked, shocked.

"Because *I* want to do the pampering", Katsuki said as if it was obvious. "You know I don't really like affection, but that won't stop me from being affectionate with you. I told you I want to be the best at this shit".

Izuku gave Katsuki a curious look.

"You do like affection, though", he accused, a bit bravely. "You may not realize you do, but you do".

Katsuki sighed.

“Deku –“

“You like it when I cuddle you”, Izuku continued. “Otherwise, you’d have blown me up when I tried”.

Katsuki gave him a look.

“And you like it when I play with your hair”, Izuku added for good measure.

“*Fine,* but that doesn’t change the fact that I don’t want you to go around pampering me and doing big gestures for me. I just want us to be together”.

“But Kacchan”, Izuku smiled. “We *are* together. And maybe I want to do big gestures for you, just as much as you want to do them for me. Have you considered this?”, he raised his eyebrows, but there was humor in the gesture.

Katsuki narrowed his eyes. Them, he squeezed them shut and pinched the bridge of his nose, pensive.

“I ignored your feelings again, didn’t I?”, he asked, half-ashamed.

“You did”, Izuku nodded. “But you don’t have to worry about it. I’m not upset or anything”, he reassured. “Actually, I have to say I’m really happy with what you did. The dinner, and Ground Beta, and the food. Really, I’m so grateful”, he smiled. “I’ll have to come up with a big gesture for you too, to make up for this”.

“You don’t have to make up for shit”, Katsuki said. “I’m the one who’s redeeming here”.

Izuku’s smile faltered a bit, and Katsuki noticed it.

“What?”, he frowned upon Izuku’s reaction, concerned.

“Nothing”, Izuku said out of habit. But then, he realized he needed to be honest – that was the rule they had agreed upon. So taking a deep breath, he added: “It’s just, from the way you said it, it sounded like you’re only on a date with me to… make up for the past”.

Katsuki watched him with attention.

“I am making up for the past”, he said. “But that’s not the reason I’m dating you. I’m dating you because… you know. Because of the l-word”.

Izuku gave him a sad smile.

“Can’t even say it, huh?”, he teased half-heartedly.

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“I love you. There, said it”, he said grumpily. “But even if I love you now, I did a lot of shit to you in the past. So yeah, I’d say I have a long way of redemption ahead of myself. And that doesn’t change what I feel”.

“Kacchan”, Izuku said patiently. “You don’t have to redeem for anything. I already told you I forgive you”.

“Yeah, you gave me that forgiveness out of the fucking kindness of your heart or some shit. I didn’t *earn* it”.

“Kacchan –“

“I didn’t *earn* it, Deku”, Katsuki cut him off. “Not yet, not for everything”.

Izuku bit his lower lip. He was trying not to take Kacchan’s words to heart so far, but that task was becoming harder and harder. He didn’t want this to turn into an argument, but he couldn’t refrain from speaking his mind, either.

“I don’t want our relationship to be your martyrdom”, he said, serious. “I don’t want it to be your path of redemption. I want you to be with me because I make you happy, not because I remind you of your past mistakes”.

Katsuki reached out and grabbed Izuku’s hand. He seemed angry, as usual, but also desperate to be understood.

“You *make* me happy”, Katsuki said emphatically. “What we have isn’t my martyrdom. It’s my reminder that I can be better. I *should* be better. And you make me better. And I should always aim to the top, in everything I do. This included. So I’m going to be the best damn boyfriend this world has ever seen”.

Izuku looked up at the purple sky, which was becoming darker by the minute. Then, he lowered his gaze again.

“It doesn’t have to be a competition”, he said seriously, doing the best he could to sound gentle. “I don’t want it to be a competition. Can – Can we please not compete, at least with our relationship? I mean, we’re still rivals in the hero field, and that’s… *fine* – we push each other to our limits and we do our best. But I don’t want to be your rival in the love field. I want to do this with you, *together*. I know I said I wanted to make up for the effort you went through with this date, but, to be honest, I don’t want to have to plan ways to surprise you more than you surprise me, or, or, to have to figure out how to impress you in turn for you impressing me. What I said about me not having planned anything for our date, since I knew you would do it – this is what I meant. I want you to be my partner, not my rival”.

Katsuki sighed. He shook his head.

“I’m doing everything all wrong again”, he said. Now that Izuku thought about it, Kacchan seemed helpless. Like he desperately wanted Izuku to read his thoughts and his feelings, but failed to express what was on his mind. “I’m trying to prove a point to you, but you don’t understand what I’m saying. Why is this so fucking difficult? I’m not fucking good at this shit, I – I – Look, I’ll – I’ll just show you”, he decided, shoving his hand into his pocket.

He retrieved a small package – it was some sort of small object wrapped in a fancy wrapping paper – and placed it on the table. He slid it over to Izuku.

“I bought this for you. What I want – what I need, what I’m aiming for – is… just to make you happy. I suck at saying it, and I suck at showing it, but – there. That’s for you. I was going to wait until dessert, but… you need to know. Now”.

Izuku eyed Kacchan with a frown, then he grabbed the little package. It was light. Izuku undid the wrapping paper and stared at the object on his hand.

It was an All Might: your soulmate valentine limited edition pair of necklaces.

Izuku’s eyes immediately widened so hard that they seemed about to pop off his sockets. He stared at Katsuki as if he had seen a ghost.

“YOU BOUGHT US THE ALL MIGHT: YOUR SOULMATE VALENTINE LIMITED EDITION PAIR OF NECKLACES?!”, he squealed in an octave above his regular tone, so loud that they must have heard him all the way back to the dorms. Katsuki would have usually felt aggravated by the loud display, but this time, he felt smug about it. He smirked and leaned back against his seat.

“Looks like I did”, Katsuki said, very pleased with himself. He gave Izuku a smug look. “Am I the best or what?”

“KACCHAN THIS IS SO *SUGOI* OH MY GOD I’M SHAKING SO HARD I CAN’T EVEN OPEN IT –“, Izuku continued to say in a very loud voice, and Katsuki could see he was actually struggling with opening the little plastic bag that contained the necklaces.

With a sigh, Katsuki stood up from his seat and walked around the table, grabbing the bag from Izuku’s hand and using his teeth to rip the plastic open. He spat out the piece of plastic in his mouth and shook the bag so that the pair of necklaces would fall on his hand.

“Are you going to put it on me? Are you going to wear it too? You’re not embarrassed by it?!”, Izuku asked frantically. Katsuki positioned himself behind Izuku and slowly put the necklace around his neck, closing it in place. “Kacchan, *say something*”, Izuku pleaded.

“Yeah, I’m putting it on you. Yeah, I’m gonna wear it. No, I’m not embarrassed”, he said straightforwardly.

Once he was done putting the necklace on Izuku, he went back to his seat and sat down again, wrapping his own neck with his half of the necklace. When put together, the two necklaces composed a heart, and each of the valentines were meant to wear one half of the heart to indicate they were soulmates. One half of All Might’s smiling face was etched on each half of the hearts, and it became complete when the soulmate put their halves together. This was the sort of niche All Might merchandise that got fabricated and only die-hard fans got a hold of – which was precisely Izuku’s (and Katsuki’s, not that he would ever admit it) case.

“I can’t believe this! I always wanted this so much, this was my biggest teenage dream, Kacchan, thank you, oh, thank you!”, Izuku celebrated, his emotions all over the place. Katsuki knew how happy he was based only on the warm, bubbly feeling that was spreading through his own limbs in response to the remains of their bond.

“I don’t want to be the best out of my own personal interests”, Katsuki said, still looking at Izuku with that smug smirk on his face. “I want to be the best because that’s what you deserve. I don’t want you to want anyone else”.

Izuku was blushing from excitement and now that the necklace was on, he kept one hand on his half of the heart at all times, as if he was afraid it would disappear. Katsuki’s words only seemed to make him fluster further, and he opened and closed his mouth without saying anything as he tried to process what he had just heard and elaborate a response.

“I – Kacchan, I don’t – I won’t – I – I –“, he stuttered. Then, he took a deep breath and closed his eyes for a moment, before breathing out and meeting his boyfriend’s – *his boyfriend’s* – gaze again. “I never wanted anyone else. And I won’t ever want anyone else. I’m trying really, really hard not to be cheesy about this, but – you’re the only person for me”.

Katsuki became a little bit more serious at this statement, even if the ghost of a smile still permeated his lips.

“And you’re the only person for me”, Katsuki said. “That’s what I was trying to tell you all along. I know we still have a lot of shit to figure out, and we have a lot of shit to talk about. I’m still trying to make sense of everything I feel, and we still need to understand how this bond between us actually works. But what I do know is that I want to make you happy. Not because I’ll get happy too in return, since we’re still bound together. That used to be my mentality, but it isn’t anymore. Because now, I care about you. And I suck at putting it into words, so – just bear with me. Ok?”

Izuku was looking at Katsuki as if he was made of the rarest pieces of diamonds on Earth.

“Kacchan”, he said simply. “You cooked me an amazing dinner. You brought us to a symbolic place on our first proper date. You gave me an All Might: your soulmate valentine limited edition pair of necklaces”, he shook his head, smiling. “You’re all my dreams come true. You’re the only one I’ll ever want. And I know you want to hear it, so I’ll say it: you’re the best boyfriend on Earth”.

“Fuck yeah”, Katsuki smirked, slamming his fist on the table so hard the bowls of katsudon rattled.

“Easy!”, Izuku smiled, holding his bowl as if to prevent it from spilling its contents all over the fancy tablecloth.

“This is only the beginning”, Katsuki said, pointing a menacing finger at Izuku. “You won’t be able to imagine the *things* I’ll do to you. I really want to be the best of the best, so get ready for some serious as shit pampering, Deku”, he said in a competitive voice.

“Kacchan”, Izuku laughed. “I don’t want to be pampered, either”.

“I’ll let you pamper me if you let me pamper you”, Katsuki offered.

Izuku looked interested at this. He considered Katsuki’s offer for a moment.

“Deal”, he nodded solemnly. “I know I said I didn’t want to be your rival in love –“

“Whatever the hell that means”, Katsuki pointed out.

Izuku paused and then sighed.

“I mean I don’t want to keep competing with you when it comes to us doing nice things for each other”, he explained. “I don’t want you to do something just because that will make *me* do something in return. I want you to do things for me because you want to, because you feel good. The same goes for me. I want to make nice things for you out of the satisfaction of seeing you happy”.

Katsuki gave him a look.

“But I don’t want anything in return”, Katsuki said, confused. “Ok, I get it. You want to have the title of world’s best boyfriend too, is that it?”

Izuku blushed. He lowered his gaze.

“… M… Maybe…”

Katsuki scoffed.

“*Fine*, Deku. We don’t have to be love rivals or anything. When I say I want to be the world’s best boyfriend, it’s because I’ll always be aiming to the top when it comes to you. I don’t mean I’m better than you at our relationship or any of that shit”.

Izuku worried at his lower lip, embarrassed.

“Fine…”, he said half-heartedly.

Katsuki thought for a moment.

“What about this”, he proposed. “We can be the world’s best *couple*. How does that sound?”

Izuku looked up at him, a wide grin appearing on his lips.

“That’s good!”, he agreed.

Katsuki nodded.

“Then it’s settled. We’re the world’s best couple. No one will ever be able to match us. Icy Hot and Round Face will piss their pants trying to top us, and they’ll never succeed”, he smirked evilly.

“K-Kacchan!”, Izuku blushed, embarrassed. “You shouldn’t say stuff like that!”

“Don’t tell me what to do”, Katsuki said. “Now finish your Katsudon. I promised Mina she’d get to bring us our dessert, and I’m bet she’s dying to come here already”.

Izuku raised a suggestive eyebrow at Katsuki.

“Oh, so you care about what your friends want now, huh?”, he teased without really thinking about it. It came naturally to his lips. It only occurred to him that Kacchan might misinterpret the joke when the words were already out of his mouth.

Katsuki glared at him. Izuku froze, apprehensive, and ready to justify himself.

“Getting bold just because you get to kiss me now, huh, Deku?”, Katsuki said instead of scolding him. As if he had understood the joke. As if they were back on the same page, after so many disagreements. Izuku smiled widely. Just the fact that Kacchan hadn’t misread his intentions for once made him stupid-happy. Stupid enough to say:

“I could die happy if that means I get to kiss you forever”.

Katsuki did a nose scrunch and pulled a face at his boyfriend.

“God, you’re cheesy as fuck”, he teased.

“Hey!”

“You called for it”.

“… Yeah, I kind of did”.

They strolled, hands intertwined, as the sun set in the horizon front of them. There was a cool breeze in the air, making their hair blow lightly against their foreheads with the wind. Katsuki hadn’t brought his cane along as if not to ruin the visuals of the date, so they were moving slowly. It wasn’t like they were in a rush, anyway, and the walk was pleasant.

He wasn’t in as much pain as he had been a few days before. He could even walk with an erect posture without feeling his healing wound pulling at the stitches. This was definitely better.

“I like the color of the sky when the sun goes down”, Izuku commented, caressing the hand he was holding with his thumb.

“I know”, Katsuki replied simply. “I don’t really care about it, but I like that you do”.

Izuku smiled, lowering his head.

“I feel so blessed to be with you” he admitted after a few moments.

Katsuki huffed out an amused breath.

“Part of me wants to call you cheesy, and the other part wants to ask you to say it again”, he found it in himself to say.

Izuku chuckled.

“I really *am* blessed”, he repeated for Katsuki’s sake, bumping against his side lightly as they walked.

Katsuki hummed low in his throat.

“I’m blessed, too”, he admitted.

They continued to stroll for a few more moments in silence. They were still at Ground Beta. Their friends had been assigned the task of retrieving the table and everything else that needed to be removed from the site, in order to relieve the recovering Katsuki from that job. That left the new couple time to wander, and time to enjoy each other’s company.

“There’s something else I want to give you”, Katsuki spoke up after a few moments, as they were about to leave the street.

They stopped walking. Izuku turned to face Katsuki, who was reaching behind himself. He removed something from behind his back – he must have crammed whatever this was into the back of his pants, like Izuku himself did sometimes. Izuku noticed it was a pair of small notebooks.

He recognized one of them. His eyes widened.

“Before you say anything”, Katsuki interrupted him before he could even get started. “Don’t get angry at your mom for giving me this”, he handed the first notebook for Izuku.

Izuku stared at it and swallowed dry before he reached out and took it into his hands. He opened it and flipped through the pages with his thumb. Just one look at it was enough to tell him what it was. In the cover, it was written: *Bakugou Katsuki*.

“I’m not… angry”, Izuku admitted. He stared up at Katsuki, meeting his eyes. “Just confused”.

“You don’t have to be”, Katsuki said. “This is for you”.

He handed Izuku the second notebook. He grabbed it and turned it to read the cover.

Midoriya Izuku.

“W-What…?”, Izuku said.

He opened the notebook. His heart was beating fast inside his chest and his mind was rushed with a hundred thoughts, but from the look of it – from what he could gather –, the notebook consisted of a series of analysis about… *him*. His signature movements, his hero behavior, his weaknesses and his strengths. Little details about himself that he had never come to realize. All gathered up in Kacchan's neat handwriting, with even some illustrations to accompany it.

"Your mom gave me the notebook you wrote about me a while ago", Katsuki explained. "Now that I think about it, I think she was trying to comfort me. Or maybe show me the way you saw me. I don't really know".

Izuku lowered his head, biting at his lower lip. He wanted to feel embarrassed, but he knew he couldn't really be angry at his mom. The notebook was personal, yes, but… he and Kacchan were together, now. They had nothing to hide from each other, right?

"I read it. Especially in those six months we spent apart, I'd keep going back to it. Whenever I… missed you. Too much. I'd grab it and I'd read random pages. Because your sentiment was so clear in those pages. What you feel – or felt – for me. The way you used to do. It was all there. Etched in this stupid notebook. When I went through it, I could pretend you still admired me. I could pretend you still…", he trailed off.

There was a moment of silence.

"I never stopped admiring you", Izuku pointed out, frowning. "Or… loving you".

Katsuki sighed, but he nodded, shoving his hands into his pockets.

"I know that. But still, I… I missed you", he admitted, glaring at the floor. "So I wrote you this".

"Kacchan…", Izuku said, taking a step closer to him.

"It's nowhere near as extensive as your analysis on me", Katsuki admitted, sounding angry at himself. "I mean, you had years to do it. I had months. So take that into consideration before you start thinking you did better than me", he advised out of habit.

Izuku gave him a small smile.

"I don't think that", he pointed out.

"Tch", Katsuki clicked his tongue in response.

"I think it's amazing you did something like this", Izuku admitted. "I'm very grateful and very honored. And I can't wait to read all of it".

Katsuki stared up at the sky. Then, he lowered his gaze again and met Izuku's eyes.

"Do you believe me when I tell you I love you?", he asked, sounding uncharacteristically vulnerable.

Izuku wanted to react with a laugh, but he could sense how serious Kacchan was being about the question. He thought for a moment.

“Yes”, he admitted, smiling. “It was hard at first, but…”, he took one hand to his new necklace, smiling. “Now I don’t find it as hard. Because you… you’re better at showing it, Kacchan”.

“I’m still learning”, Katsuki argued.

“And you’re doing great at it”, Izuku smiled, squeezing his hand.

Katsuki managed a small smile that seemed a little self-deprecating. Izuku grabbed his other hand and pulled him closer, brushing the tips of their noses together.

“I can feel what you feel, remember?”, Izuku asked, nudging Katsuki.

“And doesn’t that make you afraid?”

“Afraid? Of what?”, Izuku frowned.

“That it’s your love contaminating me. Or my love contaminating you. That only one of us loves the other, and that the other one only mirrors it and thinks that they’re in love”.

Izuku frowned.

“You’ve been thinking *that*?”

Katsuki hesitated for a moment. Then, he nodded. *Honest. I need to be honest.*

“And that… that makes me fucking scared”, Katsuki concluded.

Izuku raised his eyebrows.

“Why?”

Katsuki bit his lower lip.

“I don’t want to love you on my own”.

“And what if I’m the one who loves you on my own? I’ve been doing it for quite some time, now, so it makes more sense to be me contaminating you than you contaminating me”, Izuku said, with no ill intentions. Katsuki flinched at the words, but acknowledged the truth behind them.

“Tch. I know what I’m feeling”, he argued, defensive.

“Are you sure about that?”

“Yes”.

Izuku nodded.

“I’m pretty sure I know what I’m feeling too. You’re not the only own who got better at reading your own emotions, you know”.

Katsuki lowered his head. Izuku continued holding his hand, but nudged closer to him.

“I miss you when you’re gone. And when you’re with me, the day seems brighter. The colors seem more vivid. Life seems merrier. To me, it’s been like that since day one. Ever since we were these little babies who had just gotten to know each other”, he reached to his back pocket and retrieved the photo of the two of them as toddlers.

Katsuki stared at it.

“I know it wasn’t always like this to you”, Izuku concluded. “You didn’t get butterflies in your stomach when you saw me, like it happened to me when I saw you. But I don’t care about that. I don’t care about the past. It’s over. *That’s* over. We need to stop looking at that so much. What matters to me now, what I care about now – is us. Together. Do you love me now?”

Katsuki closed his eyes, leaning his forehead against Izuku’s.

“I love you”.

“And do you want to be with me?”

“I do”.

No hesitation.

Izuku smiled tenderly.

“Me too, Kacchan. So please, don’t blame yourself for what is over. Don’t think you need to atone”.

“I do need to atone”.

“Not to me, you don’t”, Izuku said. “I’ve already forgiven you for everything. And I hope you have forgiven me too, for whatever way I might have wronged you. For all those times I hurt you”.

Katsuki took the pictures from Izuku’s hand, staring at them.

“I’m not nostalgic or anything”, he said. “But I’m glad my mom kept these”.

“I’m glad too”, Izuku smiled. “Can I make a copy later?”

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“You can keep them”, he handed them back to Izuku. “I bet your mom will love to have them on her album”.

“But Kacchan”, Izuku frowned. “They’re yours”.

“They’re *ours*”, Katsuki corrected him. “I’m not the only one in those pictures. We can keep them, together. We can own a *lot* of shit together. Your All Might collection is all half-owned by me, now”.

Izuku’s face became very serious and he visibly tensed up.

Katsuki smirked.

“I’m *joking*”, he said.

Izuku sighed in relief and his posture visibly relaxed. He even managed to smile awkwardly.

“What about the pictures Mina-san took of us?”, he asked.

Katsuki gave him a confused look.

“Uh, she managed to take photos of us”, Izuku clarified. “When you weren’t looking. It was after she brought us dessert. I didn’t say anything because I didn’t want to kill the mood by having you go after her”.

Katsuki frowned at Izuku, then he huffed indignantly through his nose.

“I should have known she would have pulled some shit like that”, he said, glaring at the side.

“I’m actually… glad she did?”, Izuku smiled tentatively. “I didn’t want to, uh… make you uncomfortable or anything. But I wanted to keep our first date in my memory forever. And I’m glad someone took the pictures of us. I would have done it myself, but I…”, he trailed off, embarrassed.

“You what?”, Katsuki frowned.

“I didn’t know if you’d want that”, Izuku shrugged. “I know you don’t really like photos”.

Katsuki studied his face.

“Do *you* like photos?”, he asked.

Izuku worried at his lower lip.

“Kacchan…”

“It’s a pretty simple question”, Katsuki urged.

Izuku sighed.

“I do”, he admitted. “I never had any friends growing up, so now that I do… I like to keep record”.

Katsuki nodded.

“Then let’s do it”.

Izuku’s eyes widened and his cheeks became pink.

“W-What?”, he asked, nervous.

“Let’s take a fucking picture”, Katsuki clarified. “I’m not gonna have a low-quality, distant pic taken by Raccoon Eyes as the only memento from our first date. If it’s important to you, I’ll do it. C’mon”, he said, picking his phone from his pocket and opening the frontal camera.

“Kacchan!”, Izuku exclaimed, taken aback. “But you don’t like it!”

Katsuki rolled his eyes.

“I don’t mind it. I wouldn’t go around taking pics of myself doing basic stuff, because I’m not an idiot like Mina. But our first date is an important moment, and you want to keep it on record. So let’s do it”.

“I don’t want to make you uncomfortable”, Izuku pointed out again, hesitant. Katsuki sighed.

“You’re not making me uncomfortable, otherwise I wouldn’t be doing this”, he said. Then, he grabbed Izuku by the waist and pulled him closer. “Smile”.

Izuku put on a nervous smile at the same second Katsuki snapped the picture of their faces glued together. The sun was still setting behind them, and the purple sky contrasted against their hairs.

Katsuki inspected the photo with a nose scrunch, looking up at Izuku.

“That’s not your regular smile”, he accused.

“W-What?”, Izuku frowned.

“When you smile for real, your dimples pop up”, he said, poking at Izuku’s cheek with his index finger.

“I… Guess I’m not really good at posing for photos”, Izuku rubbed the back of his neck, embarrassed. “I always end up ugly when I do”.

Katsuki scowled at him.

“Just think about something funny and smile your regular smile”, he instructed, putting the phone up again in order to snap the photo.

“Kacchan!”, Izuku protested. “I don’t know how to do that!”

“You’re the one who wanted to take the photo, now you say you don’t know how to do it?”, Katsuki argued.

“I didn’t think *you* would want to take the photo, now I’m out of my depth! Let’s just – take it another day. It has to be natural”, he suggested.

“No natural moment will keep being natural once someone pulls out their phone to take a picture of it”, Katsuki pointed out. “Come on. Just smile your Deku smile”.

“*Kachaaaan*”, Izuku protested.

“Do it!”, Katsuki poked at his ribs. “Don’t make me tickle you. I remember you were ticklish as a brat”.

“Kacchan! Don’t tickle me!”, Izuku pleaded.

“Then smile, goddamn it!”, Katsuki said, poking at Izuku’s rib again. Izuku doubled on himself, giggling maniacally. “See? There you go!”, Katsuki celebrated.

“Kacchan – stop, I – I’m gonna –“, he laughed, and then laughed louder as Katsuki tickled his side again. “Nooo, stop! I’m gonna have a laughing fit –“

“That’s the goal”, Katsuki snorted, raising the phone again to take the picture. Izuku smiled nervously at the camera again, but Katsuki used his free hand to tickle his side, which made Izuku laugh loudly again and throw his head back desperately.

Katsuki snapped the picture and let go of Deku’s side. The outcome wasn’t great, but it was a nice capture of the little moment they had shared. In the picture, Izuku was smiling widely with his head thrown back, two dimples on each side of his freckled cheeks. Katsuki, on the other hand, was staring at Izuku rather than the camera, a playful, defiant smirk on his lips. Behind them, the sky was a mixture of purple and dark blue, a few stars shining in the distance.

“I – I can’t believe you remembered – I was ticklish –“, Izuku panted beside him, tears in his eyes. He hadn’t seen the photo yet, and before he could, Katsuki put the phone away in his pocket and crossed his arms above his chest.

“Of course I remember”, Katsuki said. “When we both were brats, I’d always tickle you whenever I lost an argument, just to pretend I hadn’t lost”.

Izuku narrowed his eyes playfully at him.

“Oh, so that was why you did it?”, he said with an accusing tone.

“Wow, Deku, your brain is so quick”, Katsuki teased. “Only took you 13 years to figure that out”.

“Hey!”, Izuku protested, tapping Katsuki’s arm. “I can’t believe you did that!”

“My goal is always to win, no matter the consequences”, Katsuki tilted his chin up. “Even if that means having you piss yourself from laughing too hard”.

“Oh, like that time you pissed the bed during our sleepover and tried to blame it on me?”, Izuku raised his eyebrows teasingly at him. Katsuki opened his mouth in an ‘o’ shape, offended.

“Oi, what did you just say?”, he asked, but Deku started to take several steps back, away from him.

“I bet you can’t catch me and make me say it to your face!”, he said, and then he started running away.

“Oi, you bastard! I’m still recovering, I shouldn’t be running!”, Katsuki shouted back at him, going after him with rushed steps that quickly became a jog, despite his worry about his injury.

“’My goal is to win, no matter the consequences’, huh?”, Izuku turned on his heels to shout at him, and then he started running away again.

“*Matte yo*, Deku!”, Katsuki yelled playfully.

Katsuki caught up to Izuku, who had slowed his pace for his boyfriend’s sake. He took Izuku’s hand and held it into his own firmly. Izuku was still laughing, and happiness was emanating from him so hard that Katsuki found himself smiling as well, until he was laughing too. They started walking more slowly in order to prevent Katsuki from putting more strain on his injury, and bumped against each other playfully as they strolled down the street.

Together, they walked side by side as equals, holding hands as they strolled into the blue horizon.

THE END

Chapter End Notes

This is all, folks. I'm finally happy with the way the story has ended. It took me a lot of meds and a lot of perseverance to reach the place that I am at right now. It's been almost three years of writing this story, and I consider it to be my magnum opus. I went through so many ups and downs during the writing process, and now I'm happy to say I'm finally at a better spot, mentally and physically.

Every single one of you deserves kudos for reading this and supporting me. I hope you all enjoyed this story just as much as I enjoyed writing it, despite the rough spots I went through sometimes. I will always cherish this story and the ones who read it and liked it in my heart.

There will be no further The Way You Used To Do chapters. This is truly the end. There is an in-progress sequel to this story (When The Chips Are Down) and maybe there will be more separate works in the future that are set after the events of TWYUTD. But as for TWYUTD itself, it's over. After all, part of the journey is the end :'-)

Kudos to everyone who get the Oresteia reference.

End Notes

This is my first work for the BNHA fandom, so I hope it turned out well!
Comments and feedback are deeply appreciated, I want to know how I'm doing! Kudos make a writer happy too ♥
Twitter: Twitter
Tumblr: Tumblr
Bluesky: Bluesky

Works inspired by this one

Camomila by edema_ruh

When the Chips Are Down by edema_ruh

A Devastating Liberation by edema_ruh

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!